A 900-DAY PATH THROUGH SCRIPTURE

Catechism.

A Bible Reading Plan for New Believers

Learn the Bible.
Learn the faith.
Learn to read it yourself.

Read a passage, understand it, see Christ in it, and respond to God in your own words. Six days of reading and one day of rest, for two and a half years.

900	25	66	44	150
DAYS	UNITS	BOOKS	DOCTRINAL PAUSES	PSALMS

CATECHISM

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Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 1 · DAYS 1-16

Creation and the Covenant of Works

Genesis 1-3

Who is God, and what is man? The foundations of all Christian doctrine.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

Creation psalms (8, 19:1-6, 29, 33:1-9, 65, and 104) answer Genesis 1 and 2 with praise.

UNIT 1

In this unit

WEEK 1		
1	Genesis 1:1-2:3	*Reading*
2	2 Timothy 3:14-17; 2 Peter 1:16-21	*Doctrine*
3	Genesis 2:4-25	*Reading*
4	Genesis 1:26-28; Genesis 9:6; James 3:9	*Doctrine*
5	Genesis 3:1-24	*Reading*
6	Genesis 3:1-24; Romans 5:12-21	*Doctrine*
7	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*
WEEK 2		
8	Psalm 8	*Psalm*
9	Psalm 104:1-23	*Psalm*
10	Psalm 104:24-35	*Psalm*
11	Psalm 19:1-6	*Psalm*
12	Psalm 33:1-9	*Psalm*
13	Psalm 29	*Psalm*
14	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*
WEEK 3		
15	Psalm 65	*Psalm*
16	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 1 · WEEK 1

Genesis 1:1-2:3

God speaks creation into existence; the six days; the goodness of all things

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Reading · 34 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 1:1-2:3 slowly, and aloud if you can. It is the opening of the Bible and takes about five minutes. Notice the rhythm of the six days and the line that keeps returning: "And God saw that it was good." Read it once for the story, and once more asking what it tells you about God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Genesis is the first book of the Pentateuch, the five books of Moses, and was written for Israel as they prepared to enter the land God promised to Abraham. The original audience had just been delivered from slavery in Egypt, where they had lived for four hundred years under a culture full of competing gods: the sun, the river, the storm, and Pharaoh himself, who was called divine. Genesis 1 was a direct answer to all of that. It told them whose world they actually lived in.

This opening chapter is also the beginning of the entire biblical story, the foundation on which every covenant, every promise, and every redemptive act will rest. Before there can be a story of redemption, there must first be a creation worth redeeming. Before there can be a Savior, there must first be a Creator. Genesis 1 tells us who God is, what kind of world he made, and what humanity was made for. Everything that follows in Scripture depends on getting this beginning right.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The chapter follows a clear pattern: "And God said… and it was so… and God saw that it was good." Notice how often this rhythm repeats. Counting them is itself an act of observation.

2. There is a parallel structure between the days. Days 1-3 form realms (light/dark, sky/sea, land/vegetation), and Days 4-6 fill those realms with their inhabitants (sun and moon, fish and birds, animals and humans). Creation is ordered, not chaotic.
3. God speaks. He does not struggle, fight, or shape creation out of pre-existing material that opposes him. He commands, and reality obeys.
4. The creation of humanity is set apart. There is a divine deliberation ("Let us make man in our image"), a doubling of the verb "created" in verse 27, and the explicit blessing and commission given to no other creature.
5. The seventh day is the climax, not the sixth. The creation of humanity is the high point of the work, but the Sabbath is the high point of the week.
6. The phrase "it was good" appears seven times. After humanity is made, it becomes "very good." Goodness is woven into the fabric of what God has made.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 1 is not primarily concerned with how God created or how long it took. Its concern is who God is, what he made, and what kind of world we live in. Every other ancient creation story in the world that Israel encountered, Babylonian, Egyptian, Canaanite, featured gods who fought, struggled, killed one another, or formed the world out of corpses and chaos. Genesis 1 stands utterly apart. There is one God. He is sovereign over all things. He creates by speaking, not by struggling. And what he makes is good.

The opening verse establishes everything: "In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth." Before there was time, there was God. Before there was matter, there was God. He is not part of the created order; he is its source. The Hebrew word for "created" here is bara, a verb used only of God, never of human making. It signals something only God can do: bring into existence what was not there before.

Then comes the pattern. God speaks, and what he says becomes reality. Light comes into being at his word. Land separates from sea at his word. Plants grow, stars appear, creatures swim and fly and walk, all at his word. This is the doctrine of creation by divine speech, and it carries enormous theological weight. It means God's word is not advisory or decorative; it is creative. What God says, is. When you later read that the gospel comes to you "through the word," or that you are "born again by the imperishable seed of the word," remember that the same word that called galaxies into existence is now calling sinners into new life.

The chapter unfolds in a deliberate, beautiful symmetry. Days 1, 2, and 3 form realms, God separates light from darkness, waters above from waters below, and dry land from sea. Days 4, 5, and 6 fill those realms, sun and moon for day and night, birds and fish for sky and sea,

animals and humans for the land. The world is not random. It is shaped, ordered, and prepared like a home being made ready for its inhabitants. And the chief inhabitant for whom the home is prepared is humanity.

When the sixth day arrives, the pattern shifts. God deliberates: “Let us make man in our image, after our likeness.” The plural is striking, Christian readers have long seen here the first hint of the triune nature of God, though the doctrine of the Trinity is not yet articulated. What is articulated is that humanity is unique. Of every other creature, God said “Let the earth bring forth” or “Let the waters swarm.” But of humanity, God said “Let us make.” Humanity bears God’s image, male and female together, blessed, commissioned, and given responsibility over creation. This is the foundation of all Christian anthropology. Every human you will ever meet bears the image of God.

And then, on the seventh day, God rests. Not because he is tired. He rests because the work is finished, and rest is the goal of the work. The Sabbath is woven into the fabric of creation before any law is given. It tells us that the universe has a purpose, and that purpose is not endless production but communion with God in restful joy. Every Sabbath the church gathers, every Lord’s Day a believer enters worship, points back to this seventh day, and forward to the eternal rest that awaits the people of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Day 1 is the foundation. There is no previous reading to build on, but everything that follows in this plan will build on this. The God who speaks here is the same God who will call Abraham, deliver Israel from Egypt, give the law at Sinai, raise up David, send his Son, and pour out his Spirit. The world he makes here is the same world that will be cursed in Genesis 3, redeemed at the cross, and renewed in the new heavens and new earth. Watch how often the rest of Scripture echoes this chapter: John’s Gospel opens “In the beginning was the Word,” directly mirroring Genesis 1:1. Revelation closes with a new creation that fulfills what began here. The whole Bible is in some sense the story of how God brings his good creation to its appointed rest in Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Begin where Scripture begins: with God as Creator. This is not a doctrine you accept once and move past. It is the lens through which you see everything else. Because God made you, you have inherent dignity that no one can give and no one can take. Because God made your body, your body is not a prison or an accident, it is good. Because God made the world, your

work in the world matters; gardening, parenting, building, studying, serving are all forms of carrying out the mandate given to humanity in the image of God. Because God made the Sabbath, your rest is not laziness but worship.

Today, consider one practical response: where in your life have you been treating something God made as either worthless or as ultimate? The created order points beyond itself to its Creator. Eat your food with gratitude. Take in a sunset and let it lead you to praise. Treat the people around you as image-bearers worthy of dignity. And when you grow tired, let your weariness remind you that the goal of creation is not endless work but the rest of God himself, a rest finally fulfilled in Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as Creator, and thank him for one thing in your life you have received as a gift from his hand.
- Ask him to open your eyes to see his goodness in ordinary things today.
- Tell him what you want to learn about him as you begin this journey.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 1

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

DAY 2 · WEEK 1

2 Timothy 3:14-17; 2 Peter 1:16-21

The Doctrine of Scripture (Bibliology)

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Timothy 3:14-17 and 2 Peter 1:16-21 prayerfully. These are the two most direct New Testament passages on what Scripture is and where it comes from. Read each twice, slowly. Notice how Paul speaks of Scripture, and notice how Peter speaks of the prophetic writings. Read aloud if you can.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Today is the first doctrinal pause day in the plan. Throughout these two years, the regular flow of reading will be interrupted occasionally by a day devoted to articulating a major Christian doctrine, not because doctrine is separate from Scripture, but because Scripture itself teaches doctrine and asks us to think clearly about it. These days take a short passage of Scripture as the anchor and explore the teaching that emerges from it.

Before going further in this plan, we need to settle a foundational question: why trust this book? Yesterday you read Genesis 1, and across the next two years you will read every other book of the Bible. But every word of every reading rests on a prior conviction, that the Bible is not merely a human collection of religious literature, but the very word of God to humanity. The two passages you just read are where the Bible most directly tells us what it is and where it came from. Before we read anything else, we need to know what we are reading.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Paul tells Timothy that he has known the “sacred writings” from childhood, these were the Old Testament Scriptures. Paul assumes the OT is Scripture.
2. The phrase “breathed out by God” (theopneustos in Greek) is striking. Scripture is not just inspired in the way poets are “inspired”; it is the very breath of God in written

form.

3. Scripture is described as "profitable" for four things: teaching, reproof, correction, and training in righteousness. It both informs and forms.

4. The goal of Scripture is the maturity and equipping of the man of God, "complete, equipped for every good work." Scripture is sufficient.

5. Peter writes that the gospel message is not "cleverly devised myths." He claims eyewitness authority and points to the prophetic word as "more fully confirmed."

6. The famous phrase "men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit" uses a sailing metaphor, the human authors were genuinely active, but the Spirit determined the direction.

7. Both passages root Scripture's authority in God himself, not in human committees, religious institutions, or personal experience.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The doctrine of Scripture, sometimes called bibliology, is the foundation of every other Christian doctrine. If we cannot trust this book, we have nothing to say about God, sin, salvation, the church, or the future. So the first question is the most important: what is the Bible?

The Bible's own answer is that it is the inspired Word of God. The Greek word Paul uses, theopneustos, does not mean that God's people came up with religious ideas and God endorsed them. It means that Scripture is breathed out by God himself. The human authors wrote real letters, with their own vocabularies, personalities, and circumstances, but what they wrote, God wrote. Peter's image of being "carried along" by the Spirit (the same word used of a ship driven by the wind) captures the same point: God's authorship works in and through human authorship, not around it.

From this doctrine of inspiration flows four other claims the church has historically made about Scripture.

First, inerrancy. Because Scripture is breathed out by God, and because God cannot lie or be mistaken, Scripture in its original form does not err. This does not mean every translation is perfect, or that every word must be read with a flat literalism. It means that when properly understood, Scripture does not lead us into falsehood. What God teaches in his Word is true.

Second, authority. Because Scripture is God's Word, it has the authority God has. To submit to Scripture is to submit to God; to dismiss Scripture is to dismiss God. The Bible is not one voice among many that the Christian considers; it is the voice to which all other voices are

accountable.

Third, sufficiency. Paul says Scripture is enough, that through it the believer becomes "complete, equipped for every good work." Christians do not need new revelations, secret traditions, or extra-biblical mystical experiences to know what God requires of them. Scripture contains all that is necessary for salvation, faith, and life.

Fourth, clarity (or perspicuity). The Bible is not so obscure that only the highly trained can understand it. The main message, who God is, what humanity has done, what Christ has accomplished, how we are saved, is clear enough that an ordinary believer reading prayerfully can grasp it. This does not mean every passage is easy. It means the gospel is not hidden.

A few common misunderstandings deserve mention. Inspiration does not mean dictation, as if the human authors were typewriters and God pressed the keys. The authors' personalities and styles are visible everywhere. Authority does not mean the church's authority over Scripture, but Scripture's authority over the church. Sufficiency does not rule out the use of pastors, teachers, study aids, or tradition, it rules out treating any of those as equal to Scripture. And inerrancy applies to what Scripture teaches, not to incidental matters about which it makes no claim.

When we approach the Bible, we approach the voice of God himself. That is why every study of the faith begins here, and why every Christian's life of discipleship is sustained, by the regular, prayerful reading of Scripture.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The two passages you read make claims about Scripture that nothing else in the world makes about itself. Paul calls the Bible the breath of God. Peter says its writers were carried along by the Holy Spirit. These are not modest claims, and they have shaped Christianity from the beginning.

Consider Paul's words to Timothy first. Paul is writing to a young pastor who is facing opposition, false teaching, and discouragement. What does Paul tell him to rely on? Not his own giftedness, not his connections, not even Paul's continued mentorship, but the Scriptures he has known from childhood. Why? Because they are "able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus." This is a remarkable statement. Paul does not say Scripture is one tool among many; he says it has the power to bring a person to saving wisdom. The Bible does what no other book does. It carries the breath of God.

Peter's testimony adds a different angle. He is writing as someone who has seen the transfiguration with his own eyes. He could appeal to his apostolic eyewitness, and he does. But then he says something stunning: we have the prophetic word "more fully confirmed." More confirmed than his own eyewitness experience. Why? Because Peter knows that even his experience must be tested by Scripture, not the other way around. He calls Scripture "a lamp shining in a dark place." Not a lamp that helps a bit, but the lamp by which we navigate the darkness of this age.

This is the posture every Christian must take toward the Bible. The world we live in is full of competing voices, cultural assumptions, personal feelings, political loyalties, religious traditions. None of these is wholly absent from a Christian's life, and not all of them are bad. But none of them is the voice of God. When they speak against Scripture, they are wrong. When they align with Scripture, it is Scripture that gives them their weight. The Bible is the lamp; everything else gets its light from it.

This is also why the regular reading of Scripture is not an optional Christian habit. It is the way the breath of God reaches you. Through this book, the Spirit who carried the writers along still carries the readers along, into greater knowledge of Christ, into deeper repentance, into more mature obedience. You will not grow as a Christian apart from this book. And you do not need any other book to grow. Whatever else might be helpful, and many things are, the Bible is sufficient. The God who breathed out these words breathes them into your soul as you read them.

The implication is enormous. This is not a museum piece, not an inspirational anthology, not a religious classic. This is God speaking. When you open Scripture, the same God who said "Let there be light" is speaking to you, and what he says, taught, reproved, corrected, trained, is meant to make you complete. Approach it accordingly.

STEP 5

Connection

Yesterday you read Genesis 1, where God created by speaking. The doctrine of Scripture takes that same divine speech and tells us that what God has breathed out is not only the heavens and the earth, but also this written word. The God of Genesis 1, who spoke worlds into being, is the same God who has spoken in Scripture, and as you keep reading, you will hear his voice through every page. Every reading after today rests on what was settled here: this book is the breath of God, sufficient and authoritative, the lamp that lights our way through the entire story of redemption you are about to read.

STEP 6

Application

Trust this book. That is the practical heart of today's doctrine. Trust it when it speaks comfortably to you, and trust it when it confronts you. Trust it when it agrees with your culture, and trust it when it contradicts your culture. Trust it when it confirms what you already wanted to believe, and trust it especially when it tells you something you did not want to hear. The Bible is the breath of God; treat it as such.

Practically, this means three things. First, ask whether Scripture holds first place in your days. What would it look like for hearing God to become a habit and not a project? Second, when Scripture and your feelings disagree, trust Scripture. Feelings are real but unreliable; God's Word is reliable. Third, when teachers or churches contradict Scripture, trust Scripture. The Bible is not under any earthly authority. It is the authority over them.

There is one more practical implication: do not be afraid to read this book. Yes, it has hard parts. Yes, it asks more of you than you can give. But it was written to be understood by ordinary believers under the guidance of the Spirit. Read it humbly. Pray before you read. Read with the church when you can. And expect God to speak. He does, every time.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he has spoken, and that you are not left to guess who he is.
- Confess any place where you have trusted your own judgment over what Scripture says.
- Ask him for a humble, hungry heart toward his Word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 1

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

DAY 3 · WEEK 1

Genesis 2:4-25

The garden, the man, the woman; the covenant of works arranged

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Reading · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 2:4-25 slowly. Genesis 1 gave a wide view of creation; this chapter zooms in on the garden, the man, and the woman. Notice what God provides, what he commands, and the one thing he calls “not good.” Read it aloud if you can.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Genesis 2 is not a second, contradictory creation story. It is a deliberate narrowing, a re-telling that zooms in on Day 6 of Chapter 1 to show us how humanity, in particular, was made and where humanity was placed. In Hebrew literary form, this kind of telescoping is common: first a wide overview, then a closer look at the part that matters most for the story to follow.

What follows in the Bible, the Fall, the covenants, the long history of redemption, only makes sense if we understand what humanity was originally meant to be and where humanity was originally meant to live. Genesis 2 sets up the covenant relationship between God and Adam that the next chapter will catastrophically break.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The name “LORD God” (Yahweh Elohim) appears here for the first time. Genesis 1 used Elohim, the general word for God. Now we encounter God’s covenant name combined with that title, the same God, but now revealed in personal relationship.
2. God forms man from the dust and breathes into his nostrils. Humanity is both earthly (made of the same material as the ground) and uniquely alive with God’s own breath.
3. The garden is described in beautiful detail, trees pleasant to the sight and good for food, a river that divides into four headwaters. This is paradise, but it is also a real place.

4. There are two named trees: the tree of life and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. The command not to eat from the second is the first command God gives to humanity.

5. Adam is told to "work and keep" the garden. These same two Hebrew verbs are later used of the priests' service in the Tabernacle. Adam is, in a sense, the first priest.

6. The making of the woman is preceded by Adam discovering that nothing in creation corresponds to him. The woman is made from his side, not from his head to rule him or his feet to be ruled, but from his side as his equal partner.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 2 reveals that the creation account is, at its heart, a covenant account. The setting is a garden, Eden, but the garden is more than a beautiful place. It is the temple of creation, the meeting place between God and humanity, the original holy ground. The river that flows out of it waters the world, suggesting that what happens in this garden is meant to spread outward, that the holiness and life of God's presence is meant to extend to the ends of the earth.

Into this garden God places the man, and the words used to describe his task are loaded. He is to "work" and "keep" it, the same words later used of the priests who served in the Tabernacle. Adam is given a role that is simultaneously royal (exercising dominion) and priestly (serving and guarding the sacred space). He is a king-priest in a garden-temple, representing God to creation and creation to God.

Then comes the command. "Of every tree of the garden you may surely eat, but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die." Notice the structure: God's generosity comes first ("of every tree… you may surely eat") and the one prohibition follows. This is the pattern of all true covenant relationship with God. Grace and gift come first; obedience is the response. The single commandment is not God being stingy or cruel. It is the test of whether Adam will trust God's wisdom about good and evil, or whether he will reach out and try to define those things for himself.

This arrangement is what theologians have long called the covenant of works. God offered Adam a relationship of life and blessing on the condition of obedience. Had Adam obeyed, he would have come into the fullness of what God offered, life confirmed, blessing extended, perhaps eventually access to the tree of life itself. But the conditional nature of the arrangement also meant that disobedience would bring death. The stakes were not arbitrary; they were the natural consequence of either trusting God or refusing to.

Then the narrative slows down again. God observes that "it is not good that the man should be alone." This is the first thing in creation declared not good, and it is not a flaw in creation, but a deliberate setup. Adam needs to discover his own lack before he receives the gift of a partner. So God brings the animals, and Adam names them, exercising his dominion, but also noticing that none of them correspond to him. None is a true partner.

So God puts Adam into a deep sleep, takes a rib from his side, and forms the woman. Adam's response is the first poetry in the Bible: "This at last is bone of my bones and flesh of my flesh." Marriage is established before the Fall, before sin enters the world. It is part of God's original good design, a covenant between a man and a woman that pictures, in its own way, the deeper covenant between God and his people. The chapter ends with the haunting line: "And the man and his wife were both naked and were not ashamed." There was no fear, no hiding, no covering. That is the world we lost.

STEP 5

Connection

Yesterday we saw God speak the cosmos into existence. Today we see him stoop to the dust and form a man with his own hands. The same God who is transcendent over creation is also intimate with his creatures. This is the God whose Son will later "take on flesh and dwell among us," who will gather children in his arms, who will form a new humanity from his pierced side as Adam's bride was formed from his. The pattern of Genesis 2, a man, a garden, a tree, a bride, will echo throughout Scripture all the way to the new creation in Revelation 22, where the tree of life appears again, and the river flows again, and the bride of Christ is finally united to her husband forever.

STEP 6

Application

If you are tempted today to think God is distant or impersonal, return to Genesis 2. The God of the Bible is not aloof. He kneels in the dust to form humanity. He plants a garden by hand. He breathes his own life into Adam's nostrils. He notices when his creature is alone and provides for him. This is the kind of God you serve.

Practically, consider three things today. First, your body is not a problem, it is part of God's design, formed by God himself. Treat it as such. Second, work is not a curse from the Fall; it was given before sin entered. The work you do this week is part of God's image-bearing commission. Do it well. Third, the relationships God has given you, spouse, family, friends, church, are reflections of the original "it is not good for man to be alone." You were not made for isolation. Show up. Be present. Let the people God has put in your life see your face without shame, as far as it is possible.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for making you a creature with a body, a place, and relationships, and tell him if any of that is hard to receive as a gift.

Ask him to show you what he has placed in your care.

Speak to him about any place where you are tempted to doubt his good word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 1

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

DAY 4 · WEEK 1

Genesis 1:26-28; Genesis 9:6; James 3:9

The Image of God

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 1:26-28, Genesis 9:6, and James 3:9 prayerfully. These three passages are short, but they are the foundation of everything the Bible says about being human. Read them aloud if you can. Notice how each one applies the doctrine of the image of God to a different situation.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Two days ago you read Genesis 1, where God made humanity in his image. Yesterday's doctrinal day set the foundation of Scripture itself. Today we take the central claim of Genesis 1, that humanity is the image of God, and explore what it actually means. This is the most important question any human being can ask: what am I, and why does my existence matter? The Christian answer is not that humans are slightly evolved animals, or accidentally meaningful collections of atoms, or self-defining beings free to invent their own purpose. The Christian answer is that every human being bears the image of God, and that this image carries with it dignity, vocation, and destiny.

The three short passages you read today show this doctrine applied in three different ways: as the source of human dignity at creation, as the basis for the sanctity of life after the flood, and as the reason ordinary speech matters in everyday Christian behavior. The doctrine is not abstract; it presses on every part of human existence.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Genesis 1:26 uses a plural, "Let us make man in our image", which Christians have long seen as a hint of the triune nature of God.

2. The image of God is given to humanity as male and female together, not to one sex alone. Both fully bear the image.
3. The image is connected immediately to a commission: "be fruitful and multiply… have dominion." Image-bearing is not just a status; it is a vocation.
4. Genesis 9:6 grounds the prohibition against murder in the image of God. To take a human life is to assault the One whose image that life bears.
5. James 3:9 applies the image of God to speech, cursing other people is incompatible with worshiping God, because those people bear God's image.
6. Across all three passages, the image of God is never said to be partial or lost. Even fallen humans, even violent humans, even people we are tempted to curse, still bear it.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The doctrine of the image of God, what theologians call the imago Dei, is one of Christianity's most distinctive contributions to human thought. Every Christian doctrine about humanity begins here. To answer the question "what is a human being?" Christians answer: a creature made in the image of God.

But what does that mean? Theologians have offered three main approaches that emphasize different aspects of the biblical witness.

The first is the substantive view, which says the image consists in some quality humans share with God, rationality, moral capacity, self-awareness, a soul, the ability to know God. There is something to this. Humans are unlike other creatures in their capacity for abstract thought, moral reflection, language, and worship.

The second is the relational view, which emphasizes that humans were made for relationship, with God, with one another, with creation itself. We image God not just in what we are, but in how we relate. The fact that Genesis 1 says we were made "male and female" right alongside the image language supports this. The Trinity itself is eternal relationship, and image-bearers are made for relationship too.

The third is the functional view, which highlights the immediate commission given in Genesis 1: dominion over creation. In the ancient Near East, kings were sometimes called the "image" of their gods, meaning the king represented the god's rule on earth. Humanity, plural and equal, is given that role. We are not gods, but we are God's image-bearers, his representatives in the world he made.

The fullest understanding includes all three. We image God in our being (rationality, morality, capacity for worship), in our relating (to God, to one another), and in our doing (representing his rule in creation). The image is not one thing; it is the whole shape of what it means to be human.

A critical implication: the image of God was damaged but not destroyed by the Fall. Genesis 9, written after the Fall, still grounds the value of human life in the image of God. James, written to Christians, still calls fellow humans image-bearers. Sin distorts the image; it does not erase it. Every human being you will ever meet, your closest friend, your worst enemy, the unborn child, the elderly grandmother with dementia, the criminal, the saint, the stranger you will never know, bears the image of God. This is the ground of universal human dignity.

But there is more. The New Testament reveals that the image of God is most fully expressed not in fallen Adam, but in Christ. Paul calls Jesus "the image of the invisible God" (Colossians 1:15). Christ is what we were meant to be, the true human, the second Adam. And through union with Christ, believers are being "transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another" (2 Corinthians 3:18). Sanctification is the restoration of the image. Heaven is the image fully restored.

So when you ask "what am I?" the Christian answer comes in three tenses. You were made in God's image. That image was marred in the Fall. And in Christ, that image is being restored, and one day will be perfectly fulfilled in glory.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three passages you read show the doctrine of the image of God doing actual work in Scripture. None of them stops at "humans are special." Each one draws an ethical conclusion from the doctrine.

Genesis 1:26-28 sets the foundation. Notice the structure: God deliberates ("Let us make"), God acts ("So God created"), and God commissions ("Be fruitful… have dominion"). Image-bearing is not a passive identity; it is a calling. To be made in God's image is to be tasked with reflecting God's rule in the world. Marriage, family, work, creativity, stewardship of the earth, all of these flow from this opening commission. When you raise children, build something, grow a garden, organize a project, or care for a place, you are doing image-bearing work.

Genesis 9:6 takes the doctrine into the most extreme ethical territory: the taking of human life. Right after the flood, as humanity begins again, God establishes the boundary that protects human life: "Whoever sheds the blood of man, by man shall his blood be shed, for

God made man in his own image." The reason given is theological, not pragmatic. Murder is not just a social problem or a personal tragedy. It is an attack on the image of God himself. This is why every human life, regardless of usefulness, age, ability, or status, carries an irreducible weight. To diminish a human being is to insult the One whose image that human bears.

James 3:9 brings the doctrine right into ordinary life: how you talk. "With it we bless our Lord and Father, and with it we curse people who are made in the likeness of God." James sees a contradiction, and notice what he calls the contradiction. Not that we are inconsistent in our speech, or hypocritical, though those things are true. The contradiction is that the same God we praise has made the people we curse in his own likeness. You cannot worship God on Sunday and despise your spouse, coworker, neighbor, or political opponent on Monday. They bear the image of the One you claim to worship. Image-bearing makes every encounter with a human being an encounter with the dignity of God himself.

This is why Christianity has, throughout history, been the source of the strongest claims about universal human dignity. Not because Christians have always lived consistently, they haven't, but because the doctrine forces the issue. If every human bears the image of God, then slavery is wrong, infanticide is wrong, racism is wrong, abuse is wrong, neglect of the poor is wrong. Not wrong because we feel they are, but wrong because God has put his image in every person, and you cannot trample on that image without trampling on God himself.

The doctrine also means something about you. You are not nothing. You are not a mistake. You are not less than anyone. The God who made the stars made you in his image, called you good, and gave you a calling to image him in the world. Whatever lies you have believed about your worth, whether from yourself or from others, Genesis 1 outranks all of them.

STEP 5

Connection

In Genesis 1 the image of God was given. In Genesis 3 (which you read yesterday) that image was marred, humans began to image themselves as gods rather than to image the true God. But the image was not lost. Every page that follows in the Bible assumes humans still bear it: that is why Cain's murder of Abel matters in Genesis 4, why the law protects the dignity of every Israelite, why the prophets thunder against the abuse of the poor. And the whole story climaxes in Christ, the perfect image of God in human form. Through union with him, the image in us is being restored. The doctrine of the image of God runs from Genesis 1 to the new creation, where image-bearers will reign with Christ over the renewed earth, finally being what we were always meant to be.

STEP 6

Application

Treat people as image-bearers. That is the daily, practical heart of this doctrine. The cashier at the store, the driver who cut you off, your spouse on a hard day, the colleague you disagree with, the family member who has hurt you, the stranger on the corner asking for change, each of them bears the image of the same God you worship. You cannot honor God while dishonoring his image.

This works two directions. It calls you to higher respect for others than the world's standards of usefulness or attractiveness or moral worth would suggest. And it calls you to higher respect for yourself than your own self-loathing might allow. You are an image-bearer. So are they. The doctrine permits neither contempt of others nor self-contempt.

Today, identify one person in your life who is hard for you to honor. It might be someone who has wronged you, someone you find irritating, someone you have written off, or someone you simply do not notice. Think of that person as one who bears the image of God. Pray for them. Speak kindly of them, or at least refuse to speak cruelly. And ask the Spirit to keep forming Christ, the true image of God, in you, so that one day your imaging of God will be as true and as full as his.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you were made in his image, and tell him where you struggle to believe it about yourself.

Ask him to show you someone you have treated as less than an image bearer, and to change how you see them.

Praise Jesus as the perfect image of the Father.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 1

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

DAY 5 · WEEK 1

Genesis 3:1-24

Temptation, the Fall, the curse, and the first gospel promise

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 3:1-24 slowly, and aloud if you can. This is the saddest chapter in the Bible and the most important for understanding everything that follows. Notice what the serpent asks, how Adam and Eve respond, and how God appears in the story, both in judgment and in promise (look closely at verse 15).

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday we saw the world as it was meant to be: a garden, a man, a woman, work and rest, presence and partnership, no shame. Today everything changes. Genesis 3 is the story of how the very good creation of chapters 1 and 2 was broken. But more than that, it is the chapter that explains every news headline, every funeral, every estrangement, every disease, every disordered desire you have ever experienced. The whole biblical story of redemption assumes Genesis 3. Without this chapter, the gospel makes no sense, because without this chapter, there is nothing for the gospel to fix.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The serpent does not begin with a direct contradiction. He begins with a question: “Did God actually say…?” Doubt is planted before disobedience.
2. Eve’s response slightly distorts God’s command, she adds “neither shall you touch it.” The slightest drift from God’s actual word makes further drift easier.
3. The serpent finally contradicts God directly: “You will not surely die.” He then accuses God of withholding something good, “you will be like God.”
4. The order of the temptation is striking: the woman saw that the tree was good for food (the appetite), a delight to the eyes (the senses), and to be desired to make one wise (the

mind). 1 John 2:16 echoes this triad.

5. Adam was "with her." He was not deceived in the same way; he failed in passive silence.
6. Their first response to sin is shame, they suddenly know they are naked and try to cover themselves. Their second is hiding from God. Their third is blame, Adam blames the woman (and implicitly God for giving her), the woman blames the serpent.
7. Verse 15 is the first gospel promise: the offspring of the woman will crush the serpent's head. Before any curse is even spoken to humanity, a promise of victory is given.
8. God himself clothes them with garments of skin, the first death in Scripture is an animal slain to cover human shame.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 3 is the most consequential chapter in the entire Old Testament. Everything in human experience that you grieve, every relational wound, every body that breaks down, every system that goes wrong, finds its origin here. And yet, before the chapter ends, the gospel has already been promised. This is both the worst news in Scripture and the moment when the best news begins.

The temptation is subtle. The serpent does not roar in declaring God a liar; he whispers a question. "Did God actually say...?" Doubt always precedes rebellion. Notice what is being attacked: not God's existence, not even God's power, but God's word. If God's word cannot be trusted, if it is unclear, or stingy, or designed to keep us from something better, then disobedience starts to feel reasonable. The serpent's whole strategy is to make God seem less generous than he is. He frames God's one prohibition as if it were God's whole posture: "Did God actually say you shall not eat of any tree?" But God had said the opposite, eat of every tree, except this one. Generosity comes first, prohibition is the exception. The serpent inverts it.

Eve's response begins well but slips. She defends God's generosity, but then she adds something God never said: "neither shall you touch it." It is a small drift, but every great failure begins with a small drift from God's actual word. The serpent then makes his move. He flatly contradicts God ("you will not surely die") and slanders God's motives ("God knows that when you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God, knowing good and evil"). The accusation is that God is holding out on them, that obedience keeps them from their true potential.

And here is the heart of all sin: the desire to define good and evil for ourselves, to be like God on our own terms. Eve's eyes go to the fruit. It is good for food, pleasing to look at, and seems to offer wisdom. Three categories of desire are activated, appetite, beauty, ambition, and she

takes. The Hebrew word translated “took” is the same word later used for taking another man’s wife or seizing what is not yours. It is the language of theft. And Adam, who has been “with her” through the whole exchange, takes too, in silence.

What happens next is the world we now live in. Their eyes are opened, but not to be like God. They are opened to shame. They cover themselves with leaves. They hide from God when he comes walking in the garden. When God confronts them, they blame, Adam blames Eve, and implicitly God himself (“the woman whom you gave to be with me”); Eve blames the serpent. Sin always fractures relationships. With God, with each other, with creation itself.

Then come the curses. The serpent is cursed first. The woman’s pain in childbearing and her relationship with her husband are disordered. The man’s work, once a joy, will now be filled with thorns and sweat. And finally death, “to dust you shall return.” The full weight of God’s earlier warning falls. But there, in the middle of the cursing of the serpent, comes verse 15: “I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel.” This is the protoevangelium, the first gospel. Before any judgment is pronounced on humans, before any human is sent out of the garden, a promise has already been made: a son of the woman will one day come and crush the serpent’s head. The cost will be real, the serpent will bruise his heel. But the victory belongs to the woman’s offspring.

And then, in a quiet act of mercy, God makes garments of skin and clothes Adam and Eve. Animals die to cover human shame, the first hint of a sacrificial principle that will run through the entire Bible, all the way to a cross where the Lamb of God will bear the sin of the world.

STEP 5

Connection

Yesterday’s covenant of works has been broken. The man and woman who were placed in the garden as priest-king and partner have failed the test, and the consequences fall on themselves, their children, and the creation entrusted to them. But the story does not end with the curse. Genesis 3:15 is the seed from which every later promise grows, the promised offspring of Abraham, the suffering servant of Isaiah, the son of David, the Word made flesh. When Romans 16:20 says God will “soon crush Satan under your feet,” it is echoing Genesis 3:15. When Christ on the cross declares “It is finished,” he is fulfilling Genesis 3:15. The whole Bible is the unfolding of the promise made in this chapter, that the seed of the woman would do what Adam failed to do, and would crush the head of the one who deceived humanity.

STEP 6

Application

Look at the serpent's strategy and recognize it, because it is still in use today. "Did God actually say…?" The accusation that God is withholding something good. The framing of obedience as oppression and disobedience as liberation. These are the same temptations you will face this week, this year, your whole life. The defense is not stronger willpower. The defense is a settled trust in God's word and God's character. The serpent could not have succeeded if Eve had said: "Whatever God said, he said because he is good. I do not need to be like God; I am made by God, and that is enough."

Today, consider one place in your life where you are tempted to think God is holding out on you. Maybe it is a desire you are being asked to wait on or set aside. Maybe it is a command that feels restrictive. Bring it before God honestly. And then remember that the very God who gave that command is the God who, in this same chapter, made the first promise of a Savior, and who, in the fullness of time, sent his only Son to crush the serpent and clothe sinners not in leaves but in his own righteousness. Your trust in God's word and your trust in God's love are not separable. Trust both today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess in your own words where you have listened to the serpent's doubt about God's word or goodness.

Thank God for the promise of the one who would crush the serpent, and tell him what that means to you.

Ask him to clothe you in Christ rather than in your own coverings.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 1

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

DAY 6 · WEEK 1

Genesis 3:1-24; Romans 5:12-21

The Doctrine of Sin (Hamartiology)

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Re-read Genesis 3:1-24, yesterday's passage, and then read Romans 5:12-21. These two passages together form the backbone of the Christian doctrine of sin. Genesis tells the story; Romans tells you what the story means. Read slowly, especially the Romans passage, which is one of the densest in the New Testament.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday you read the Fall in Genesis 3, the narrative of how sin entered the world. Today we step back to ask the larger question: what exactly happened, and what does it mean for every human being who has ever lived? This is the doctrine of sin, sometimes called hamartiology.

The doctrine of sin is the most empirically verifiable doctrine in all of Christianity. You see its effects every day, in yourself and in everyone you know. The problem is not knowing whether something is wrong with humanity. The problem is understanding what is wrong, how deep it goes, and what can be done about it. Genesis 3 and Romans 5 give us the answer. Today we explore what they teach.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Romans 5:12 traces sin and death back to one man: "sin came into the world through one man, and death through sin." The doctrine of original sin is not invented; it is taught.
2. Notice the parallel Paul builds: "as by the one man's disobedience the many were made sinners, so by the one man's obedience the many will be made righteous" (5:19). Adam and Christ stand opposite each other.

3. Death is described as reigning "from Adam to Moses, even over those whose sinning was not like the transgression of Adam." Death affects even those who did not personally break a specific command.

4. The Greek word for "sin" (hamartia) means "missing the mark", failing to be or do what God made us to be and do.

5. Genesis 3 shows sin entering through doubt of God's word, distrust of God's character, and the desire to define good and evil for oneself.

6. The first effect of sin is shame and hiding. The image-bearers who walked with God now flee from him.

7. Sin's consequences ripple outward: from the relationship with God (alienation), to the marriage relationship (blame), to the body (death), to the ground itself (cursed).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Christian doctrine of sin makes four claims that distinguish it from every other diagnosis of the human condition.

First, sin is universal. Every human being, without exception (Christ alone excepted), is a sinner. This is not a claim about culture or upbringing or environment. It is a claim about human nature itself, since the Fall. "All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God" (Romans 3:23). You did not choose to become a sinner; you were born one. Even before you committed your first conscious act of disobedience, you were already inheriting the corrupted nature passed down from Adam.

Second, sin is deep. The traditional name for this is "total depravity," and the term is often misunderstood. It does not mean every human is as evil as they could possibly be, clearly people are capable of impressive virtues, kindnesses, and acts of love. What it means is that sin has touched every part of human existence, the mind, the will, the affections, the body, the conscience. There is no part of you that is untainted, no morally neutral zone that sin has not penetrated. This is why Paul says even our good works, apart from Christ, are insufficient. Sin runs all the way down.

Third, sin is inherited. This is the doctrine of original sin. When Adam fell, he did not fall as a private individual but as the federal head of humanity, the representative in whom all his descendants are reckoned. Paul makes this explicit in Romans 5: through Adam, sin and death spread to all. This is why babies die, why every culture in every era produces both wonders and atrocities, why your own heart deceives even you. The corruption did not start with you; it was waiting for you the moment you were conceived.

Fourth, sin is offensive to God. This is what makes sin sin and not merely failure or error. Sin is a moral assault on the holiness of God. It is treason against the rightful Lord of creation. It deserves judgment, not just because God is angry, but because God is just. A holy God cannot be indifferent to sin without ceasing to be holy.

These four claims paint a picture darker than most modern people are comfortable with. But notice what they make possible. If sin is universal, no one can save themselves by being a better person, and so no one is left behind, every human equally needs grace. If sin is deep, surface-level moralism cannot fix us, and so the gospel offers a new heart, not a self-improvement program. If sin is inherited, salvation must also be inherited from a new representative, and that representative is Christ, the second Adam. If sin is offensive to God, it must be punished, and Christ has taken that punishment on himself.

The doctrine of sin is bad news. But every Christian doctrine of grace is only good news because of how bad the news of sin is. The depth of the disease tells you the depth of the cure. If sin were only a failure of effort, Christ's death on the cross would be absurd overkill. But if sin is what Scripture says it is, then Christ's death is precisely what we need.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 3 and Romans 5 together tell us not just what sin is, but how it works.

In Genesis 3, sin begins with doubting God's word. The serpent's first question is "Did God actually say?" Before Eve had eaten anything, the soil of her heart was being prepared for rebellion by being asked to question what God had spoken. This is still how sin operates today. Long before a Christian falls into open disobedience, the foundation has usually been laid by questioning whether God really said what he said, really means what he means, really cares what he cares about. Watch the pattern. Sin always starts with the word.

Then sin moves to distrust of God's character. The serpent does not just question the content of God's word; he attacks God's motives. "God knows that when you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God." Translated: God is holding out on you. He is not generous; he is stingy. He is not a good Father; he is a withholding tyrant. This lie is in every temptation you face. If you could see that God is good and that his command is for your flourishing, sin would lose almost all of its power. But the serpent works to make God look smaller, meaner, and less trustworthy than he is.

Finally, sin culminates in self-deification, the desire to be the one who decides what is good and what is evil. This is the heart of sin. Not just disobedience to a command, but the assertion of moral autonomy: I will define right and wrong for myself. Every sin is, in some

sense, a small repetition of this. Whenever you choose to override what God has said because you have decided your way is wiser, kinder, more loving, or more reasonable, you are echoing Eden.

Romans 5 then takes this story and tells you why it matters for you. Paul's argument is breathtaking in its scope. The world we live in, full of death, decay, injustice, futility, is the world that Adam's sin has brought about. Not because each of us has personally sinned the way Adam did (though we have), but because we are all in Adam. The technical term is "federal headship." Adam represented humanity. His fall was our fall. His exile was our exile. His death is our death.

But that is not the end of Paul's argument. He sets up the contrast precisely so he can flip it. If one man's disobedience could plunge all of humanity into sin and death, then one man's obedience can lift all who are in him out of sin and death. That second man is Christ. Just as we were in Adam by birth, we are in Christ by faith. Just as Adam's failure was counted as ours, Christ's success is counted as ours. Just as we inherited death from Adam, we inherit life from Christ. The whole gospel hinges on this parallel.

So the doctrine of sin is not Christianity's primary message. It is the dark background against which the bright news of Christ stands out. You cannot understand the gospel without it. You cannot rejoice in the cross until you have grieved over Eden. But once you have done both, you will see the wonder of what Christ has done with a clarity that no shallower doctrine could ever produce.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1 and 2 showed us what we were meant to be, image-bearers in covenant with God, called to rule the world he made. Genesis 3 showed us what we became, exiles, hiding, ashamed, dying. The doctrine of sin is the bridge that explains every other tension in Scripture. It is why the law has to be given. It is why blood has to be shed. It is why prophets weep and kings fail. It is why God's people need a Savior, not just a teacher or a king. And it is why, when Christ enters the world in the New Testament, he comes not as a moral example to imitate but as a substitute to die. As you continue reading, you will see this doctrine confirmed at every turn, and you will see, with growing clarity, why the gospel of Christ is the only answer to the catastrophe of Genesis 3.

STEP 6

Application

Take sin seriously. This is hard in a culture that wants to soften every category and rename every failure. But you will not grow as a Christian if you minimize what is actually wrong with you. The depth of grace can only be felt by those who have honestly faced the depth of sin.

Practically, three habits help. First, regular self-examination, not in a morbid way, but honestly asking God to show you where you have sinned in the past day, week, month. The psalmist's prayer is a good one: "Search me, O God, and know my heart" (Psalm 139:23). Second, confession, both in personal prayer and, when appropriate, with trusted believers. Sin loses much of its power when it is brought into the light. Third, repentance, not just feeling bad about sin, but turning from it toward Christ, again and again.

But also, take grace seriously. The doctrine of sin is not meant to keep you in despair. It is meant to drive you to Christ. If you are in him, the verdict over you is no longer "in Adam, condemned" but "in Christ, justified." The sin still in you does not define you; Christ does. The doctrine of sin should produce humility, not self-loathing. It should produce vigilance, not paranoia. It should produce gratitude, because you know what you have been rescued from.

If you have never trusted in Christ as the Savior who bore your sin and gave you his righteousness, today is a good day to do so. The serpent's lie was that God is not good. Christ's death is the answer: God is so good that he sent his own Son to bear what we deserved.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God honestly what you see when you look at your own heart, and ask for his mercy.
- Thank Jesus for doing what Adam failed to do.
- Ask him to keep you close to the cross, taking sin seriously and grace more seriously still.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 1

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

DAY 7 · WEEK 1

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This is your weekly Sabbath, a day to rest from the work of new content and to let what you have read this week settle into your heart. If you can, set aside your normal time for this rest day just as you would for any reading day. The discipline of stopping is its own form of worship.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

GENESIS 1:1

REST

Meditation

Spend a few minutes saying this verse aloud. Say it slowly. Say it again. The goal of weekly memory work is not perfection but possession, by the end of this week, you should be able to recall this verse from memory without effort.

Sit with the verse phrase by phrase. "In the beginning", there was a beginning, and God was already there. "God created", not chaos, not gods, not accidents. "The heavens and the earth", everything that is, in every realm. Seven English words that refute atheism, polytheism, pantheism, dualism, and naturalism all at once.

Carry this verse with you through the day. When you see something beautiful in creation, say it. When something feels chaotic in your life, say it. When you wake tomorrow, say it again. By next week, it will be yours.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This was the first week of the plan. You began with creation itself, Genesis 1, the ordered making of all things by the speech of God. You paused on the doctrine of Scripture and learned why this book carries the very breath of God. You read Genesis 2 and saw humanity as image-bearers in covenant with their Maker. You paused again on the image of God, what it means to be human, and why every person you meet bears irreducible dignity. You read Genesis 3 and watched the fall, the first sin, the first promise of a Redeemer. And you paused a third time on the doctrine of sin, universal, deep, inherited, offensive to God, and the very thing Christ came to bear.

Six days. Three readings. Three doctrinal anchors. This is the foundation under everything else you will read in the next two years. The God who created. The image he made. The Scripture he gave. The sin we committed. The Redeemer he promised. Every page that follows builds on what you read this week.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

What is one thing about God's character this week that struck you in a new way? The first chapters of Genesis introduce God as Creator, as the one who speaks, as the one who walks with his people, as the one who calls humans into covenant, as the one who pursues them even after they have fallen. Where did your sense of who God is deepen this week?

How does this week's reading point you to Christ? The doctrine of Scripture you read on Day 2 reaches its climax in the Word made flesh. The image of God you read about on Day 4 is fully and perfectly seen in Jesus, the true image of the invisible God. The doctrine of sin you read on Day 6 is the very catastrophe Christ came to undo. Where have you seen Christ in the foundations this week, and where do you most need to bring your sin and rest in his finished work?

What does it mean for you, today, that every person you encounter bears the image of God? Whose face will you see this week that you have not been treating as an image-bearer?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the week behind you, and for one thing he has shown you about himself.

Rest in what he has done instead of what you must still understand, and say so to him.

Ask him to settle the memory verse in your heart.

DAY 8 · WEEK 2

Psalm 8

The glory of God in creation and the dignity of man

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 8 slowly, twice, and aloud if you can. It is short, only nine verses. Notice that it begins and ends with the same line, and notice the question in the middle: “What is man that you are mindful of him?” Let the psalm lead you to look at the night sky as the psalmist did.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Psalms are the prayer book of the Bible, the songs, laments, and praises that the people of God have prayed for three thousand years. They were sung in the Temple, prayed by Jesus on the cross, and read in the church from the beginning. This plan weaves them in alongside the historical books because the Psalms teach us not just what God has done, but how to respond to him. Psalm 8 is the first Psalm we will read together, and it is fitting: it picks up exactly where the last three days have left us, meditating on the same creation and the same dignity of humanity that Genesis 1-2 described.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens and closes with the same line: “O LORD, our Lord, how majestic is your name in all the earth.” This is called an inclusio, it frames the whole psalm in worship.
2. Babies and infants are mentioned in verse 2 as the means by which God establishes strength against his enemies. Strength comes from unexpected places in God’s economy.
3. The psalm moves from the cosmic (the heavens, the moon, the stars) to the personal (what is man that you are mindful of him?) and back to the cosmic.

4. The question “what is man?” is asked in the middle of looking at the night sky. Smallness is felt; the answer comes anyway: humanity has been crowned with glory and honor.

5. Verses 6-8 echo Genesis 1:26-28, dominion over the works of God’s hands, all things under his feet.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 8 is David’s response to the same wonder that Genesis 1 and 2 set up. Looking at the night sky, David asks the question every honest person eventually asks: in this enormous universe, why does humanity matter? The stars are vast. The moon hangs distant and unchanging. Compared to the cosmos, a human being is small, fragile, and temporary. So why does God care?

David’s answer is not that humanity is, in fact, more impressive than it seems. It is that God has chosen to crown humanity with glory and honor. The dignity of humans is not earned, it is given. We have value because God has assigned us value, made us in his image, and given us responsibility over what he has made. Verse 6 directly echoes Genesis 1:28: “You have given him dominion over the works of your hands; you have put all things under his feet.”

But the psalm has a depth that the New Testament will later uncover. When the writer of Hebrews quotes Psalm 8 in Hebrews 2, he applies it to Jesus. “You have crowned him with glory and honor”, yes, that is true of humanity in general, but it is most truly fulfilled in the one true human, the second Adam, who succeeded where the first Adam failed. Jesus is the man who actually fulfills the role Psalm 8 describes, the human under whose feet all things will finally be subjected. Already, Hebrews says, we see him “crowned with glory and honor because of the suffering of death.” The dignity of humanity, lost in Genesis 3, is recovered in Christ.

So Psalm 8 is both a celebration of the dignity God has given us and a confession of the wonder that God should bother with us at all. It is honest about smallness. The night sky humbles. But the smallness only makes the love of God more astonishing. He sees you. He knows your name. He has crowned you with glory and honor. This is the truth that Christianity proclaims against every philosophy that says humans are accidents and against every culture that reduces humans to their usefulness.

STEP 5

Connection

For three days we have been reading Genesis, the creation, the garden, the fall. Psalm 8 is the appropriate response. It looks at what God has made and worships. It looks at what God has done for humanity and marvels. And it does so without yet knowing what we know, that the one truly crowned with glory and honor will be Jesus, the Son of David, in whom the dignity of humanity is finally restored. Pray this Psalm today as someone who knows the rest of the story.

STEP 6

Application

Read this Psalm again, slowly, as a prayer. When you reach the question "what is man that you are mindful of him?", let yourself sit with both the smallness and the dignity. You are smaller than you think and more loved than you can imagine.

This week, look at the sky at night, if you can. Let it remind you of how vast God's creation is, and let that vastness lead you to worship rather than despair. Then look at the people around you, your spouse, your children, the cashier at the store, the stranger in traffic, and remember that each of them has been crowned with glory and honor by God. The doctrine of human dignity is not a slogan; it is a practice. It changes how you treat the people God has made.

And finally, look at yourself. If you have ever wondered whether you matter, Psalm 8 answers you. The God who counts and names every star is mindful of you. The maker of galaxies cares about your life. You are not an accident, and you are not insignificant. You are an image-bearer crowned with glory by the Creator of all things, and in Christ that glory is being restored.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Stand in wonder before God's majesty, and tell him what stirs in you when you think of how small you are and how much he has given you.

Thank him that Christ restores the dignity Adam lost.

Ask him to help you see each person you meet today as crowned with honor.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 2

"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork."

PSALM 19:1

DAY 9 · WEEK 2

Psalm 104:1-23

God as creator, O LORD, how manifold are your works

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 104:1-23 slowly, twice. This psalm retells the creation story as praise. As you read, see if you can match its verses to the days of Genesis 1, and notice how God is pictured as providing for every creature, from the wild goats to the lions to the people who work the land.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 104 is one of the longest creation poems in the Bible, and it follows the same order as Genesis 1: light, heavens, waters, earth, vegetation, sun and moon, creatures, humanity. The psalmist appears to be deliberately taking us back through Genesis 1, but as praise rather than narrative. If Genesis 1 is the architect's blueprint, Psalm 104 is the hymn sung when you walk through the finished house and marvel at the craftsman. Today's reading covers the first two-thirds, through the work of the day. We will save verses 24-35 for another day in the plan.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with the same call as Psalm 103: "Bless the LORD, O my soul." This is self-talk, the psalmist commanding his own heart to worship.
2. God is described as clothed in splendor and majesty, wrapped in light, riding on the clouds. The imagery is regal and cosmic.
3. The order of creation in this psalm mirrors Genesis 1: light, the firmament, the waters, dry land, vegetation, the heavenly bodies, the creatures.
4. Notice how much attention is given to water, springs gushing, rivers running, animals drinking. Water is life in the ancient Near East, and the psalmist sees it everywhere as

evidence of God's provision.

5. Verses 19-23 take the same heavenly bodies that Genesis 1 calls "lights" and shows them at work: the moon marks seasons, the sun governs the rhythm of work and rest for both humans and animals.

6. Even the lions are seen as "seeking their food from God", predators included in the picture of God's provision.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 104 is what creation theology looks like when it is set on fire. The same God who, in Genesis 1, simply spoke and reality obeyed, is here described in vivid, sensory language. He wraps himself in light as a garment. He stretches out the heavens like a tent. He makes the clouds his chariot and walks on the wings of the wind. The psalm is not just telling us that God made creation; it is showing us that God is intimately involved with every part of it.

This is a crucial corrective to a common misunderstanding. Many people, even Christians, drift toward a kind of deism, the idea that God created the world like a watchmaker, wound it up, and now stands back to watch it run. Psalm 104 refuses that picture. God is not absent from his creation. He is sustaining it moment by moment. The springs in the valleys are flowing right now because God makes them flow. The grass grows for the cattle because God makes it grow. The young lions roar because God provides their food. Every animal you have ever seen drink from a stream is participating in the providence of God.

The structure of the psalm mirrors Genesis 1 deliberately. The same order, light first, then heavens, then waters, then dry land, then vegetation, then heavenly bodies, then animal life, but where Genesis tells you what God did, Psalm 104 tells you that God is still doing it. The verbs are present tense. He is making the wind his messenger right now. He is covering the earth with the deep right now. He is making springs to gush forth right now. This is the doctrine of providence, that God's care of his creation did not stop at the end of the sixth day. It continues, every second, in every corner of what he has made.

Verse 23 is especially worth lingering on. After describing the night when the lions hunt, the psalm says: "Man goes out to his work and to his labor until the evening." Human work is part of the rhythm of creation. The sun rises, animals retreat, humans go out to labor, all of it under God's ordering. The work you will do today, however mundane, however tiring, is part of the symphony of creation that Psalm 104 is celebrating. You are not interrupting God's work by going to your job. You are participating in it.

This is the kind of meditation Psalm 104 teaches us. To see creation rightly is to see the Creator behind every part of it. To look at a tree is to see God's craftsmanship. To feel rain on your face is to feel God's provision. To hear birds in the morning is to hear what God is feeding right now. The whole world becomes a sanctuary when you read it through this psalm.

STEP 5

Connection

The first three days of this plan walked through Genesis 1 to 3. Yesterday we let David teach us how to respond to the creation account with Psalm 8, the dignity of humanity. Today the psalmist takes us deeper into the wonder of creation itself. Tomorrow we will return to narrative as Genesis continues. The Psalms are not interruptions to the story; they are the heart's response to the story. As the plan unfolds, watch how the Psalms keep reframing what we have just read in the language of prayer, lament, and praise. The Bible is not just telling you about God; it is teaching you how to talk back to him.

STEP 6

Application

Today, take Psalm 104 with you. As you go through your day, practice what the psalmist practices: noticing God's hand in what would normally be background. The water from your tap. The food on your plate. The light in the sky. The wind in the trees. The birds you hear. None of these are accidents. All of them are God's ongoing creative care, sustained moment by moment by his word.

If you have time, take a short walk outside today and let Psalm 104 shape your eyes. Notice five things you might normally walk past, and silently thank God for each. The point is not to feel mystical, the point is to recover sight. We live in a world that has trained us to see creation as raw material, as background, as something we use. Psalm 104 trains us to see it as a hymn we are walking through. Recovering this vision changes how you treat your food, your body, your environment, and your neighbor. Worship begins with seeing.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bless the LORD for something you can see or touch right now that he is sustaining.

Ask him to help you receive today's work and meals as gifts and not as entitlements.

Tell him what it would mean to walk through this day as through a temple.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 2

"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork."

PSALM 19:1

DAY 10 · WEEK 2

Psalm 104:24-35

Creation praises its maker; the Spirit renews the face of the ground

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 104:24-35 slowly, twice. Yesterday you read the first half of this psalm. Today you read the conclusion. As you read, notice how the psalm shifts from describing creation to praising the Creator, and how it ends with a startling line about the wicked, before closing in worship.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second half of Psalm 104, the great creation hymn we began yesterday. The first half walked us through the order of creation in the same sequence as Genesis 1. Now the psalmist steps back to take in the whole picture, the manifold works of God, the dependence of every creature on his hand, the sea and its creatures, the cycle of breath and death, and finally the worship that all this should produce. The psalm ends as it began: "Bless the LORD, O my soul."

For new believers, this Psalm is a school of seeing. It teaches us to look at creation not as a backdrop or a resource but as a hymn of God's craftsmanship.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 24 is the great summary: "O LORD, how manifold are your works! In wisdom have you made them all." The whole psalm is gathered into one cry of wonder.
2. The sea, often a symbol of chaos in the Bible, is here just another part of God's well-ordered domain. Even Leviathan, the great mythic sea monster, is reduced to a creature who "plays" in the water.
3. Every living thing is described as dependent on God for food, breath, and life itself. When he opens his hand, they are filled; when he hides his face, they are dismayed.

4. Verses 29-30 form a remarkable picture: God "takes away their breath" and they die, then "sends forth your Spirit, they are created", the language of ongoing creation through the Spirit.

5. The psalmist's response is to commit himself to lifelong praise: "I will sing to the LORD as long as I live."

6. Verse 35 is jarring: "Let sinners be consumed from the earth, and let the wicked be no more." Even a creation psalm acknowledges that something is wrong with the world.

7. The psalm closes with "Praise the LORD", the first appearance of the word "Hallelujah" in the Psalter.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The second half of Psalm 104 takes everything described in the first half and gathers it into one great act of worship. Verse 24 is the hinge: "O LORD, how manifold are your works! In wisdom have you made them all; the earth is full of your possessions." Every creature, every detail, every system in the natural world is the work of God's wisdom. The psalmist is not just looking at the world; he is reading it as a manuscript of divine craftsmanship.

The sea passage is especially worth pausing over. In the ancient Near East, the sea symbolized chaos, danger, and the realm where gods battled monsters. But Psalm 104 reframes it completely. The sea is just another part of God's good order. Ships pass through it. Creatures live in it. And Leviathan, the dreaded sea-monster of pagan mythology, is reduced to a creature that "plays" in God's waters like a dolphin in a tide pool. The God of Psalm 104 has no rivals. What other religions feared, he created and tamed.

Then comes the most theologically rich section: verses 27-30. Every creature looks to God for food. When he gives, they are filled. When he hides his face, they are dismayed. When he takes away their breath, they die. When he sends his Spirit, they are created and the face of the ground is renewed. Christian readers have always noticed the trinitarian echoes here, Father, Spirit, and the implicit Word, at work in ongoing creation. The Spirit who hovered over the waters in Genesis 1:2 is still active in sustaining and renewing what God has made. Creation is not a one-time event in the distant past. It is a present, continuous act of God.

The psalm reaches its climactic resolve in verses 33-34: "I will sing to the LORD as long as I live; I will sing praise to my God while I have being. May my meditation be pleasing to him, for I rejoice in the LORD." The right response to creation is not awe alone, or even gratitude alone, but worship, the deliberate, sustained, lifelong singing of praise to the Creator. This is what creation is for. It is not just a stage on which human dramas unfold. It is a sanctuary in which the Creator is to be worshiped.

And then, just when you expect a peaceful close, comes verse 35. “Let sinners be consumed from the earth, and let the wicked be no more.” It is a jarring line in such a serene psalm. Why is it here? Because the psalmist cannot praise creation without acknowledging that something is wrong with creation. The world that God called “very good” is now full of sinners and wickedness. Genesis 3 has happened. The psalm refuses to be naive about this. Praise of the Creator and longing for the renewal of creation are not in tension, they belong together. The same God who made all things will one day cleanse all things. And until then, the believer praises him both for what he has made and for what he will yet do.

The psalm closes with “Bless the LORD, O my soul. Praise the LORD.” The first “Hallelujah” in the Psalter. Worship is the final note.

STEP 5

Connection

For two days you have been meditating on Psalm 104, God’s creation as ongoing wonder. But notice how the psalm refuses to stop at creation. It ends with a longing for the wicked to be no more, and with an unrestrained burst of praise. This is the same arc you will see throughout this plan: the Bible never stays at creation alone, because creation is broken. The story moves through Fall, redemption, and toward new creation. Psalm 104 already feels the tension and looks forward to the resolution. When you reach Revelation at the end of this plan, the new creation will be the answer to Psalm 104:35, wickedness will be no more, and creation will sing the praise of God forever.

STEP 6

Application

Spend some time today simply praising God for creation. Not as a meditation technique or a stress-relief practice, but as the response that creation itself demands. The psalmist resolved: “I will sing to the LORD as long as I live.” Can you say the same? If not yet, can today be a day to begin?

Practically: walk outside if possible, even briefly, and let yourself see. Notice three things, a tree, the wind, a bird, the warmth of the sun, anything. Name them silently as gifts. Then say, in your own words or in the psalmist’s: “How manifold are your works, O LORD! In wisdom you have made them all.” Worship begins with seeing, and seeing must become saying.

But also, do not flinch from verse 35. The world is broken. There is wickedness in it, in others and in your own heart. Praise of creation that ignores this is dishonest. The Christian’s praise of the Creator always includes a longing for the Creator to come and make all things new. Pray today not just “thank you” but also “come, Lord Jesus.” Both prayers belong in the mouth of every believer who reads Psalm 104.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for the wisdom in what he has made, in your own words.

Thank him for the Spirit who renews, and ask him to renew something in you that feels worn out.

Pray “Come, Lord,” longing for the day when all things are made new.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 2

“The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork.”

PSALM 19:1

DAY 11 · WEEK 2

Psalm 19:1-6

The heavens declare the glory of God

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 19:1-6 slowly, twice. This is the opening section of one of the most famous psalms in Scripture. C.S. Lewis called it "the greatest poem in the Psalter and one of the greatest lyrics in the world." Notice the wordless preaching it describes, and how creation itself becomes a sermon.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 19 is famously structured in three movements: the first six verses praise God for his revelation in creation, the next five praise him for his revelation in the law, and the closing verses turn to personal prayer. Today's reading covers the first movement only, the wordless witness of the heavens. The plan will return to verses 7-14 on another day, when the law has become more central to our reading.

This first section is a meditation on what theologians call general revelation, the knowledge of God that is available to all people, everywhere, through what he has made. Long before any Bible reaches a human soul, the heavens are already preaching.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The first verse is one of the most quoted in Scripture: "The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork."
2. The preaching of creation happens "day to day" and "night to night", it never stops.
3. Verse 3 contains a striking paradox: "There is no speech, nor are there words, whose voice is not heard." Creation's witness is wordless but universally audible.
4. The "voice" of creation has gone out "through all the earth", Paul will quote this verse in Romans 10:18 to describe the spread of the gospel.

5 The sun is described in vivid poetic imagery, a bridegroom emerging from his chamber, a strong man running his course with joy.

6 Nothing in creation is hidden from the sun's heat, a poetic image of how thoroughly God's witness penetrates the world.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 19:1-6 makes a quiet but enormous claim: God has not left himself without a witness. Every star, every dawn, every sunset, every breath of wind has been speaking about him since the beginning. The witness is constant ("day to day pours out speech, and night to night reveals knowledge"), universal ("their voice goes out through all the earth"), and silent. This is what is meant by general revelation.

The wordlessness matters. Creation is not preaching with sermons or sentences. It is preaching with its very existence. The fact that there is something rather than nothing, that the something is ordered rather than chaotic, that the something is breathtakingly beautiful rather than merely functional, these things are themselves a testimony. As Paul will say in Romans 1, since the creation of the world, God's "invisible attributes, namely, his eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly perceived, ever since the creation of the world, in the things that have been made. So they are without excuse." Every human being who has ever lived has been preached to by the heavens.

This means something important about evangelism and missions. When the gospel arrives in a new place, it is never the first word about God that has reached that place. The heavens have already been speaking for thousands of years. The gospel is not introducing God to people who have heard nothing. It is naming and identifying the God whom every human has already been hearing about, wordlessly, since the day they were born. This is why Paul could preach in Athens by quoting their own poets, and why missionaries often find their message resonating in cultures that, on the surface, seem to have no connection to Christianity.

But general revelation has limits. The heavens declare that God exists, that he is powerful, that he is good. They do not declare that humanity is fallen, that Christ has come, or how to be saved. For that, you need special revelation, the words of Scripture, the gospel of Christ. General revelation is sufficient to leave humanity without excuse. It is not sufficient to save. That is why the psalm itself does not stop at verse 6. The next section turns to the law, the special revelation of God in his Word. Both are necessary. Both are gifts.

The image of the sun is particularly worth meditating on. The psalmist personifies the sun as a bridegroom emerging from his marriage chamber, full of joy and strength, running his course across the sky, leaving nothing hidden from his heat. This is not the sun-worship of pagans. It is the use of a vivid image to communicate something about God himself. God's revelation, like the sun, reaches everywhere. Nothing is hidden from it. The light of God's glory is the universal background of human existence, even when we close our eyes to it.

The deeper Christian reading of this image is that Jesus Christ is the true Sun of righteousness (Malachi 4:2), the one through whom God's full glory enters the world. The wordless preaching of the heavens has now been joined by the audible preaching of the Word made flesh. The same God who has been signaling himself through every sunrise has now spoken plainly through his Son.

STEP 5

Connection

For ten days now, this plan has been meditating on creation. Genesis 1 and 2 told us how it was made. Genesis 3 told us how it fell. Psalm 8, Psalm 104, and now Psalm 19 teach us how to respond to it. The pattern is becoming clear: creation is meant to lead us to the Creator, and the Creator has chosen to be revealed not only in the wordless preaching of the heavens but also, ultimately, in the spoken word of Scripture and the incarnate Word who is Christ. As you finish this first week of reading, you have begun to inhabit the basic biblical instinct: see the world, see the Maker; see the Maker, fall on your knees and worship.

STEP 6

Application

Today, let creation preach to you. The next time you step outside, the next time you see the sun rise or set, the next time you look up at the night sky, listen. The heavens are still declaring the glory of God. The question is not whether they are speaking; the question is whether you are paying attention.

A practical exercise: take a few minutes today to look at the sky. It does not need to be at a famous landmark or in beautiful weather. The sky above your driveway, your apartment building, your office, will do. Stand there for two or three minutes and let yourself hear what it is saying. Then say aloud (or silently, if that's better): "The heavens declare the glory of God." That is not a feeling; it is a fact. The sky is preaching. Your job is to receive the sermon.

But also: do not be content with general revelation. Psalm 19 itself does not stop at verse 6, and neither should you. The heavens point you to God; the Bible names him as your Father in Christ. Both belong together in the Christian life. The believer who learns to see the

wordless witness of creation and the spoken witness of Scripture is the believer whose worship is full.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that creation keeps speaking of him, and ask him to give you ears to hear it.
- Confess any days you have walked under his sky without noticing him.
- Thank him that he has spoken more clearly still in his Son.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 2

"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork."

PSALM 19:1

DAY 12 · WEEK 2

Psalm 33:1-9

By the word of the LORD the heavens were made

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 33:1-9 slowly, twice. This psalm begins with a call to worship and quickly turns to the same theme our recent readings have explored, the word of the LORD as the agent of creation. Read it aloud if you can. The psalm was originally meant to be sung.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 33 is one of the great praise psalms of the Psalter. It opens with a vigorous call to worship, shouts, songs, harps, lyres, new songs sung well. Then in verses 6-9 it grounds that worship in a specific theological claim: by the word of the LORD the heavens were made. This little psalm captures, in a few lines, what Genesis 1 narrated and Psalms 8, 19, and 104 celebrated.

The whole opening third of this plan is meditating on God as Creator. Today's psalm crystallizes one specific aspect of that doctrine: God created by speaking, and his word still carries the same power today.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with five different verbs of praise: shout, give thanks, sing, play skillfully, sing aloud. Worship is not lazy; it is energetic.
2. Praise is described as "fitting for the upright", worship is the natural and right response of the righteous.
3. Verses 4-5 ground praise in God's character: his word is upright, his work faithful, he loves righteousness and justice, the earth is full of his steadfast love.
4. Verse 6 is the theological climax: "By the word of the LORD the heavens were made, and by the breath of his mouth all their host." This directly echoes Genesis 1.

5. The Hebrew for “breath” (ruach) is the same word used for “Spirit”, the trinitarian echoes are subtle but real.
6. God “gathers the waters of the sea as a heap”, taming the chaotic waters with the ease of stacking blocks.
7. Verse 9 sums up the doctrine of creation by word: “For he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 33:1-9 is a compact meditation on what theologians call creation by divine fiat, the doctrine that God created by speaking, and that his speech carries the power to bring reality into being. It is the doctrine of Genesis 1 set to music.

The psalm begins with the call to worship. Notice the verbs: shout, give thanks, sing, play, sing aloud. Worship in the Psalter is not a quiet, internal feeling. It is a public, embodied, often loud act. The instruments are named, harp, ten-stringed lyre. The skill is required, “play skillfully.” A “new song” is called for, not just rote repetition. Christian worship has always taken this seriously. Why? Because the God we worship is worthy of more than half-hearted attention.

Then comes the foundation. Why is God worthy of this energy of praise? Verses 4-5: because his word is upright, his work is faithful, he loves righteousness and justice, and the earth is full of his steadfast love. This is the theological ground beneath worship. We do not praise God because we feel like it, or because of what we hope to get, or because praise is good for us (though it is). We praise God because of who he is and what he has done. The verbs of praise in verses 1-3 are anchored in the truths about God in verses 4-5.

Then verse 6 arrives, and it is one of the most concentrated creation statements in the Old Testament: “By the word of the LORD the heavens were made, and by the breath of his mouth all their host.” The structure is parallel: word and breath, made and all their host. The word of the LORD is not just a sound; it is the agent of creation. The breath of his mouth is not just air; it is the Spirit at work. This is why John could later begin his Gospel with “In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.” John was not introducing a new idea; he was identifying the eternal Word through whom Psalm 33:6 says the heavens were made, and revealing that Word as the Son of God.

This is the doctrine that Christians call divine speech-act. God’s words do things. When God says “let there be light,” there is light. When God says “be still” to a storm, the storm becomes calm. When God says “your sins are forgiven,” sins are forgiven. The same power that made

the universe is at work whenever God speaks. This is why the Bible matters. This is why preaching matters. This is why prayer matters. We are dealing with a God whose word is creative.

Verse 7 describes the taming of the waters, God gathers the seas as a heap. In Genesis 1, the waters of chaos were separated and ordered. In Exodus 14, the Red Sea was parted as a heap. In the Gospels, Christ walks on the water and calms the storm with a word. The God of Psalm 33 has been doing this his whole story: speaking, and chaos becoming order.

The psalm concludes the section with verse 9, which is almost a confessional summary of the doctrine: "For he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm." This is who God is. And this is the God we worship.

STEP 5

Connection

For more than a week now, this plan has been circling around creation, Genesis 1 and 2, Psalm 8, Psalm 104, Psalm 19, and now Psalm 33. Each angle has shown something slightly different: creation's order, humanity's dignity, the wordless preaching of the heavens, the still-flowing providence of God. Psalm 33 zooms in on the mechanism: God spoke. This will become crucial as the plan continues. The God who speaks the universe into being is the God who will later speak through his prophets, then through his Son, then through the apostles. The whole Bible is the speech of the God of Psalm 33:9. When we read it, we are not consulting religious literature, we are listening to the voice that made the stars.

STEP 6

Application

Take the power of God's word seriously today. Twice over.

First, when you open Scripture, remember that the same word that made the heavens is what you are reading. That is why Scripture reading is not just information-gathering. It is communion with the living God. When you open your Bible, you are sitting under the voice that called galaxies into being. Ask yourself how you usually approach it, and what would change if you came expecting to be addressed.

Second, take the energy of worship seriously. The psalm calls for shouts, songs, instruments, skill, new songs. If your worship has gone flat, if it has become a routine, a habit, a duty, Psalm 33 is a prophetic reminder that God deserves more. This is not about being emotional for its own sake. It is about giving the God who spoke the universe into being the response he is owed. Sing on your way to work. Listen to a worship song between meetings. Read a hymn before bed. Let the energy of praise come back into the corners of your week where it has slipped away.

And when you face circumstances today that feel chaotic, uncertain plans, difficult relationships, struggles in your own heart, remember verse 9. He speaks, and it comes to be. The God who tamed the waters is the same God who can speak peace into your storms.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Marvel that the God who spoke the universe into being speaks to you, and tell him what that does to the way you open his Word.

Bring him one chaotic area of your life and ask him to speak peace into it.

Ask him to revive your worship where it has gone flat.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 2

"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork."

PSALM 19:1

DAY 13 · WEEK 2

Psalm 29

The voice of the LORD over the waters

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 29 slowly, twice. This is one of the shortest and most thunderous psalms in the Psalter. Read it aloud if you can. As you read, pay attention to the repeated phrase "the voice of the LORD", it appears seven times, and it is the spine of the whole poem.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 29 is widely considered one of the oldest psalms in the Hebrew Bible. Its imagery, the LORD enthroned over the flood, the voice that shatters cedars and shakes the wilderness, uses storm-language that the surrounding pagan cultures used for their storm-gods. But the psalm radically reframes the imagery. Whatever the Canaanites attributed to Baal, the Psalter attributes to the one true God. The storm belongs to him alone.

This psalm closes our string of creation meditations in a thunderous way. Where Psalm 19 heard creation's quiet, wordless witness, Psalm 29 hears its booming, shaking, magnificent voice. Both are true, and both belong to the same God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with a call to the "heavenly beings" (literally "sons of God") to ascribe glory to the LORD. Even the angels are summoned to worship.
2. The phrase "the voice of the LORD" appears seven times in seven verses. Seven is the number of completeness in Hebrew thought.
3. Each occurrence of "the voice of the LORD" shows that voice doing something powerful in nature: thundering over waters, breaking cedars, flashing flames of fire, shaking the wilderness, twisting oaks.

4. Verse 9 ends with the surprising note: in his temple, "all cry, Glory!" Even creation's chaos becomes a sanctuary of praise.
5. Verse 10 says "The LORD sits enthroned over the flood; the LORD sits enthroned as king forever." He is not threatened by chaos; he reigns over it.
6. The psalm ends with a benediction: "May the LORD give strength to his people! May the LORD bless his people with peace!" Power leads to peace.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 29 is one of the most theologically rich short psalms in the Bible. In just eleven verses, it gathers up the doctrine of God's sovereignty, the worship of the heavenly host, the power of God's voice over chaos, and the blessing of peace upon his people. The whole psalm is built around the sevenfold repetition of one phrase: "the voice of the LORD."

The psalm begins by addressing the "heavenly beings", angels, the divine council, the celestial court. The call is for them to ascribe to the LORD glory and strength. This is significant. Worship is not just a human activity. The angels worship. The heavens worship. The whole created universe is summoned to give glory to the God who made it. When you worship as a Christian, you are not initiating a private religious moment, you are joining an unbroken cosmic chorus that has been praising God since before you were born.

Then the storm rolls in. Beginning in verse 3, the psalm describes the voice of the LORD with vivid, almost violent imagery. It thunders over the waters. It is powerful and full of majesty. It breaks the cedars of Lebanon, and the cedars of Lebanon were the strongest, tallest trees in the ancient Near East. It makes Lebanon skip like a calf. It flashes forth flames of fire. It shakes the wilderness. It strips the forests bare. The same voice that whispered in Genesis 1 also thunders. The same voice that gently spoke creation into being can shake the foundations of the world.

This is important pastoral theology. Many people, when they think of God, imagine either a gentle grandfather figure or a distant cosmic principle. Psalm 29 shatters both pictures. The God of the Bible is glorious in a way that should make the cedars tremble. He is no tame deity. He is the maker and sustainer of all things, and his voice can rip the earth open.

And yet, and this is the breathtaking turn, verse 9 ends with this surprising line: "in his temple all cry, Glory!" In the middle of all this thunder, in the holy sanctuary of God's presence, there is one response: worship. The shaking forests, the trembling wilderness, the broken cedars, they are all part of one great hymn. Even chaos cannot help but praise the Creator.

Then verse 10 brings the great theological summary: “The LORD sits enthroned over the flood; the LORD sits enthroned as king forever.” The flood here likely echoes both the Genesis flood and the chaotic waters of creation. The point is the same in both cases: God is not threatened by the chaos. He reigns over it. Whatever is shaking your life today, political turmoil, personal crisis, fear of the future, God sits enthroned over it. He is king forever.

The psalm ends, then, with a quiet benediction: “May the LORD give strength to his people! May the LORD bless his people with peace!” The God whose voice shakes the world gives strength and peace to his people. The same power that shatters the cedars protects and blesses his children. Power in the service of love is the heart of the Christian God.

STEP 5

Connection

A week ago we read in Genesis 1 that God spoke creation into being. In the days since, the Psalms have echoed that creation theme in many ways, the dignity of humanity, the manifold works of the Maker, the wordless witness of the heavens, the breath of his mouth as agent of creation. Today’s psalm completes the picture by showing us what that voice sounds like in its full power, and that it always ends in blessing for God’s people. The God who made the universe by speaking is the same God who will one day still every storm with a word, and whose voice will say to his redeemed: “Behold, I am making all things new.” The voice of the LORD has been the spine of every reading we have done. It will be the spine of everything yet to come.

STEP 6

Application

Worship God for his greatness today. Not just for his goodness, that you are familiar with, but for his greatness. The God of Psalm 29 is not a comfortable deity to manage. He is a thundering Lord whose voice shakes the wilderness. If your sense of God has shrunk to the size of your prayer requests, this psalm is a prophetic correction.

Today, find one place where you can experience something of the power of creation. The wind in trees. A thunderstorm if there is one. A vast view. The sound of a river. And let it remind you that the God you worship is the God whose voice still shakes the cedars. Then worship him for that. Not just thank him; ascribe to him glory and strength. The fact that he is so much greater than you is not bad news, it is the reason you can trust him with everything.

But also receive verse 11 today: “May the LORD give strength to his people! May the LORD bless his people with peace!” The same God whose voice splits the wilderness gives you strength and peace as his child. If you feel weak, ask for his strength. If you are anxious, ask

for his peace. The power that shook Lebanon is at your service through Christ, who has reconciled you to the King who sits enthroned forever.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ascribe glory and strength to the LORD in your own words.

Name a storm you are facing and remind yourself that he sits enthroned over every flood.

Ask him for the peace he promises to his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 2

"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork."

PSALM 19:1

DAY 14 · WEEK 2

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. After a week of creation Psalms, this is the right day to step outside if you can, look up, and simply receive what creation has been preaching. The Sabbath is not just rest from work, it is rest into worship.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork."

PSALM 19:1

REST

Meditation

Read this verse aloud several times. Then sit with the two halves. "The heavens declare", they are constantly speaking, day and night, in every place. "The glory of God", not their own beauty, not random wonder, but the glory of a Person. The sky preaches. The question is whether we are listening.

The Hebrew word for "declare" is intense, it is the language of proclamation, of a herald announcing news. The heavens are not whispering. They are heralding. Every sunrise is a sermon. Every star is a syllable in a sentence about God's glory.

Carry this verse with you outdoors today, even briefly. Look up. Hear what is being said. By the end of this week, the verse should rise to your mind every time you see the sky.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This was a week entirely of creation Psalms. You read Psalm 8, where David marveled that the God of the stars cares for humanity. You read both halves of Psalm 104, walking through creation as ongoing providence. You read Psalm 19:1-6, where the heavens preach without words. You read Psalm 33:1-9, where creation is grounded in the power of God's spoken word. And you read Psalm 29, where the voice of the LORD thundered seven times across the wilderness.

Six Psalms. One theme. Six different angles on the same truth, the world we inhabit is loud with the glory of God. After last week's foundational doctrines, this week trained you in the appropriate response to those doctrines: worship. Worship is not optional for the Christian. It is the only sane reaction to what we now know.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Which Psalm this week resonated most with you, and why? Each Psalm captured a different aspect of God's glory in creation, the stars, the storm, the silent witness of the heavens, the voice that shakes the cedars. Sit with the one that struck you most deeply. What does your response to it reveal about what you most need to learn about God?

How does the creation testimony of these Psalms point you to Christ? Paul tells us in Colossians 1 that "by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth." The Word who spoke creation into being in Genesis 1 is the same Word who became flesh and dwelt among us. Every sunrise you have ever seen was a gift from the hand of the one who would die for you. How does that change how you receive creation today?

Where has your worship gone quiet? The Psalms this week were exuberant, shouts, songs, instruments, lifted eyes. If your worship has shrunk to a routine, what would it take to recover the energy these Psalms model?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for what the heavens and the Psalms have taught you this week, and tell him what you have noticed.

Confess any distraction that has kept you from praise, and ask him to restore your wonder.

Thank Christ, through whom all things were made and hold together.

DAY 15 · WEEK 3

Psalm 65

You visit the earth and water it, God's good provision for creation

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 65 slowly, twice. This is the final psalm in our opening string of creation meditations. It is also the perfect transition: it praises God for both creation and salvation in one breath, anticipating the rest of the biblical story. Notice how the psalm moves through three movements, the forgiveness of sin, the sovereignty of God, and the blessing of creation.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 65 is in many ways the perfect bridge from Unit 1 into the rest of the plan. It is one of David's psalms, and it weaves together three themes that the plan has been building: the forgiveness of sin, the awesome sovereignty of God, and the providential blessing of creation. The psalm anticipates the harvest, likely sung at a festival celebrating God's provision of rain and crops, but it sees the harvest as woven together with God's redemption of his people.

This is the kind of psalm that teaches us how to integrate doctrines we have studied separately. Creation and salvation are not two unrelated themes; they are two acts of the same God, by the same word, for the same purpose: the flourishing of his people in the world he made.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with a remarkable line: "Praise is due to you, O God, in Zion, and to you shall vows be performed." Worship is presented as the natural posture of God's people.
2. Verse 3 is striking, sin is acknowledged immediately: "When iniquities prevail against me, you atone for our transgressions." Atonement before creation language.

3. The temple is described as the place of nearness: “Blessed is the one you choose and bring near, to dwell in your courts!”
4. God is addressed as the “God of our salvation” and “the hope of all the ends of the earth and of the farthest seas”, both personal and cosmic.
5. Verses 6-8 portray God establishing mountains, stilling the seas, and silencing the tumult of peoples, sovereignty over both nature and nations.
6. Verses 9-13 are a lyrical celebration of agricultural blessing, God “visits the earth,” enriches it with rain, fills the streams, prepares the grain, blesses the harvest.
7. The closing lines are pure exuberance: “The hills gird themselves with joy, the meadows clothe themselves with flocks, the valleys deck themselves with grain; they shout and sing together for joy.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 65 is a feast of biblical theology in twelve verses. It moves through three distinct movements, and each one builds on the last in a way that captures the whole sweep of Scripture.

The first movement (verses 1-4) begins where the Christian life begins: at the doorstep of God, with the question of how a sinner can come near. The opening is gentle, “Praise is due to you, O God, in Zion.” But then verse 3 takes a turn: “When iniquities prevail against me, you atone for our transgressions.” The honest acknowledgment of sin is immediately answered by God’s atoning work. Notice the order: sin acknowledged, atonement provided, then access granted. “Blessed is the one you choose and bring near, to dwell in your courts!” This is not vague religious sentiment. This is the gospel’s basic structure: sin, atonement, fellowship. David did not have the full revelation of Christ, but he had the substance, that God himself takes initiative to atone for sin and bring his people near.

The second movement (verses 5-8) zooms out to the cosmic. God is “the God of our salvation,” the “hope of all the ends of the earth and of the farthest seas.” His power establishes mountains, his strength girds itself, his voice stills the roaring of the seas and the tumult of the peoples. The horizon expands from personal forgiveness to global sovereignty. The God who atones for one believer’s sin is the same God who orders the nations and silences storms.

And then the third movement (verses 9-13), the one most often quoted, turns to the agricultural blessing of God in creation. “You visit the earth and water it.” “You crown the year with your bounty.” The streams are full, the grain is ready, the meadows are clothed

with flocks, the valleys deck themselves with grain. And the closing line is one of the most extraordinary in the Psalter: "They shout and sing together for joy." The hills, the meadows, the valleys, they sing. Creation itself rejoices in the goodness of God.

Now notice what David has done. He has not separated salvation from creation. He has not separated personal from cosmic. He has not separated divine sovereignty from the dew on the grass. All of it is woven together. The same God who atones for sin sustains the harvest. The same voice that silences the seas brings rain to the fields. The same hand that brings the worshiper near to his courts also crowns the year with bounty. This is the integrated vision of the Bible: there are not many gods doing many jobs in an unrelated universe. There is one God, doing one great work, of which creation and redemption are two faces.

This is also why a Christian's gratitude must always be comprehensive. We do not just thank God for spiritual blessings as if material blessings came from somewhere else. We do not just thank him for the harvest as if salvation were unrelated. Every good thing comes from the same hand, and the harvest itself, the dew, the rain, the meadows full of flocks, all of it bears witness to the goodness of the God who saves us.

Psalm 65 ends in such joy that even the inanimate creation is portrayed as singing. This is the sound of creation as it was meant to be, and as it will one day be again in the new heavens and new earth. The plan's first unit ends on this note: the doctrines of creation, fall, and the foreshadowing of redemption have been laid down. Now the rest of the story can unfold.

STEP 5

Connection

This is the last reading day of Unit 1, and Psalm 65 is the perfect summary. The unit began with creation in Genesis 1, God speaks, and the heavens declare. It moved through the fall in Genesis 3, and the first promise of a Redeemer. It paused on the doctrines of Scripture, the image of God, and sin. And it ranged through Psalms 8, 104, 19, 33, and 29, each praising the Creator from a different angle. Today's psalm gathers all of it together: sin acknowledged, atonement provided, sovereignty over nature and nations celebrated, the goodness of the harvest received with joy. Tomorrow's review day will help you consolidate what you have learned. And then we will move into Unit 2, the spread of sin and God's covenant with Noah, to continue the story.

STEP 6

Application

Receive God's goodness today, across every level of your life. The integrated vision of Psalm 65 is meant to shape how you live. The same God who forgives your sin gives you your daily bread. The same God who atones for your transgressions waters the fields that feed you. The same God who brings you near to his courts holds together the cosmos. Gratitude is meant to run wide.

Three practices for today. First, give honest thanks for one tangible blessing of creation, your food, the weather, a place you find beautiful, the breath in your lungs. Receive it as a gift from the hand that also forgives your sin. Second, examine where you have been treating the spiritual and material as if they came from different sources. Have you been thanking God on Sunday and forgetting his providence on Monday? Have you been crediting your salvation to God and your harvest to yourself? Bring the two back together. Third, let yourself rejoice. The psalm ends with hills singing and valleys shouting for joy. If creation rejoices in God's goodness, surely you can too. Joy is not optional for the Christian. It is the appropriate response to the kind of God this psalm describes.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God for one specific provision in your life this year.
- Thank him that he forgives iniquity and brings sinners near.
- Ask him to make you a joyful, thankful child today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 3

"But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD."

GENESIS 6:8

DAY 16 · WEEK 3

Review and Reflection

Unit 1 review, Creation & the Covenant of Works

Year 1 · Unit 1 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."
>
> GENESIS 1:1

REST

Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and reflection on what you have learned in Unit 1.

Begin by memorizing the verse above if you have not already. Genesis 1:1 is the foundational sentence of the entire Bible. Everything that follows, every covenant, every promise, every doctrine, rests on the claim it makes. There is a God. He created. He made the heavens and the earth. Before any biblical doctrine can be constructed, this single verse must be settled.

Say it aloud several times today, slowly. Notice each phrase. "In the beginning", there was a beginning, and God was there. "God created", not chaos, not gods, not accidents. God. "The heavens and the earth", everything that is, in every realm, from every angle, all of it. This one verse refutes atheism (God exists), polytheism (one God), pantheism (God is distinct from creation), dualism (one source, not two), and naturalism (the universe is not self-existent). All of it, in seven English words.

Carry this verse with you through the day. Repeat it when you encounter something beautiful in creation. Repeat it when something feels chaotic. Repeat it when you doubt the goodness of the world. The God who began everything is the God who oversees everything still.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 1 you have traveled through the first three chapters of Genesis and met the foundational doctrines on which the entire Christian faith rests. The unit began with creation itself, the God who speaks, the world he ordered, the humanity he crowned with glory and honor. You then descended into Genesis 3, where the rebellion of humanity broke what God had made good, and yet, even in that chapter, the first promise of a Redeemer was spoken.

Along the way, the plan paused three times for doctrinal reflection: on the Bible itself, the foundation of everything else; on the image of God, the basis of human dignity; and on the doctrine of sin, the diagnosis of what is wrong with the world and with each of us.

The Psalms then taught us how to respond to what we had learned. Psalm 8 marveled at the dignity God has given humanity. Psalm 104 led us through creation as ongoing providence. Psalm 19 listened to the wordless witness of the heavens. Psalm 33 contemplated the power of God's word. Psalm 29 thundered with the majesty of his voice. And Psalm 65 brought together creation, atonement, and joy in a single song.

This first unit has done foundational work. You have met the God of the Bible, Creator, holy, sovereign, near. You have met humanity as it was meant to be, image-bearing, dignified, in covenant. You have met sin, universal, deep, devastating. And you have heard the first whisper of grace, the offspring of the woman who would crush the serpent's head. Everything that comes next in the Bible builds on this foundation. The unit you are completing is the soil out of which the rest of the story grows.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does the order and goodness of creation reveal about God's character?

Think about what Genesis 1 shows us through its pattern and rhythm. Creation is ordered, not chaotic, speaking to God's mind. It is good, not neutral, speaking to God's character. It is given as gift to image-bearers, speaking to God's generosity. Sit with this question: if you knew nothing about God except what Genesis 1 reveals, what would you conclude about him? Write a few sentences in your own words.

What was the nature of the covenant God made with Adam in the garden?

Revisit Genesis 2. God provided abundantly ("of every tree you may surely eat"), placed one prohibition, and made it a test of trust. This is sometimes called the covenant of works. What were the terms? What was at stake? And what does the structure tell you about the pattern of all true relationship with God, gift before command, grace before obedience?

What did the Fall change about the relationship between God and humanity?

Walk through Genesis 3 in your memory. What broke between God and Adam and Eve? What broke between Adam and Eve themselves? What broke between humanity and creation? What broke inside the human heart? The Fall was not just one bad decision; it was a comprehensive shattering. Identify three specific things that changed.

Where is the first promise of redemption in Scripture, and what does it tell us?

Genesis 3:15, sometimes called the protoevangelium, the first gospel. Read it again. What does it promise? Who is the "offspring of the woman"? What does it cost him, and what does he accomplish? And how does this single verse plant the seed of everything that will follow in Scripture? Pray through this verse, thanking God that he did not abandon humanity even in the moment of our rebellion.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for what you have learned about him in these first weeks, naming one truth you want to keep.

Confess where you still resist what you have read, and ask him to keep working.

Ask him to anchor your life in the unit verse.

Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 2 · DAYS 17-28

Common Grace and the Noahic Covenant

Genesis 4-11

Sin spreads; God preserves creation for the sake of redemption.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD."

GENESIS 6:8

Psalms 9, 33:10-22, and 36:5-12 on God's care for the world and his judgment of the nations.

UNIT 2

In this unit

WEEK 3

17	Genesis 4:1-26	*Reading*
18	Genesis 5:1-32	*Reading*
19	Genesis 6:1-22	*Reading*
20	Genesis 7:1-8:19	*Reading*
21	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 4

22	Genesis 8:20-9:29	*Reading*
23	Genesis 10:1-11:32	*Reading*
24	Psalm 36:5-12	*Psalm*
25	Psalm 33:10-22	*Psalm*
26	Psalm 9	*Psalm*
27	Review and Reflection	*Review*
28	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 17 · WEEK 3

Genesis 4:1-26

Cain and Abel; sin crouching at the door; the line of Seth

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Reading · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 4:1-26 slowly. This is the first chapter after the Fall, and it shows immediately what sin does in the second generation. Notice the contrast between the two brothers, the warning God gives Cain before the murder, and the closing note about people calling on the name of the LORD.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Unit 1 ended with Adam and Eve being driven from the garden. The first promise of redemption had been given, the offspring of the woman would one day crush the serpent's head, but the immediate landscape was bleak. Today's reading is what happens next. Genesis 4 is the first chapter of life east of Eden. It shows us a world where the consequences of sin are not theoretical but lethal, and where God is still speaking, still warning, still naming his people.

This unit covers Genesis 4 through 11, the early chapters of human history before Abraham, sometimes called the "primeval history." These chapters trace the spread of sin from one family to all humanity, and the response of a patient God who preserves creation for the sake of his redemptive purposes.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Eve names Cain with what appears to be hope: "I have gotten a man with the help of the LORD." Some scholars see her hoping that Cain might be the promised offspring of Genesis 3:15.
2. Cain brings "of the fruit of the ground"; Abel brings "of the firstborn of his flock and of their fat portions." The text does not condemn agriculture, but it does say God "had regard for Abel and his offering" but "for Cain and his offering he had no regard."

3. God does not abandon Cain when his sacrifice is rejected. He warns him: “sin is crouching at the door. Its desire is for you, but you must rule over it.”
4. Cain does not respond to God’s warning. The first murder follows, and it happens to a brother, not to a stranger or an enemy.
5. When God asks Cain where his brother is, Cain echoes the deflection of his parents in Eden: “Am I my brother’s keeper?”
6. The blood of Abel “cries out from the ground”, the Hebrew is plural, “bloods”, suggesting not just Abel’s life but all his potential descendants who will never be.
7. Lamech (4:23-24) embodies sin’s escalation: he boasts of killing a young man for striking him, and demands sevenfold-times-eleven vengeance.
8. The chapter ends, unexpectedly, on a note of hope: Seth is born, Enosh is born, “At that time people began to call upon the name of the LORD.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 4 is one of the most psychologically penetrating chapters in the Bible. In just twenty-six verses, the story moves from the first act of worship after the Fall, through the first warning about sin’s nature, into the first murder, and finally to the first sustained worship of God outside the garden. It is a chapter about what happens to humanity after the Fall, and it tells us things we need to know.

The chapter begins with two brothers and two offerings. Why was Abel’s accepted and Cain’s rejected? The text gives no detailed explanation, but the writer of Hebrews tells us “by faith Abel offered to God a more acceptable sacrifice than Cain” (Hebrews 11:4). The difference was not in the type of offering but in the heart of the worshiper. Cain went through the motions; Abel offered in faith. From the very beginning of human worship after the Fall, God has cared about the heart, not just the ritual.

Then comes God’s warning to Cain, and notice what it tells us about sin. “Sin is crouching at the door. Its desire is for you, but you must rule over it.” Sin is personified as a predator at the threshold of Cain’s heart. The language echoes Genesis 3:16, where the woman’s desire is for her husband, but he will rule over her, the language of distorted, fallen relationships. Sin is not a passive failure; it is an active force seeking to consume. And critically, God speaks to Cain about it. The first warning about indwelling sin in the Bible comes from God himself, gently, before any violence has occurred. God is not absent from a fallen world; he speaks to his image-bearers even when they are angry, even when they are about to do terrible things.

But Cain does not listen. The next thing he does is invite his brother to a field and kill him. The first murder in human history is a fratricide. This is significant. The Bible does not present sin as an abstract problem; it presents it as something that ruptures the most intimate relationships. The first violence is not war between nations but a brother killing a brother. From this point forward, every act of human violence will be, in some sense, an echo of Cain, the strong against the weak, the older against the younger, the resentful against the favored, all of us against one another, all of us forgetting that the person we strike is our kin.

When God confronts Cain, Cain replies with the most famous deflection in Scripture: "Am I my brother's keeper?" The answer, of course, is yes. You are. Every human is the keeper of every other human, because all bear the image of God. Cain's question contains its own indictment.

Then God speaks of Abel's blood crying out from the ground. The Hebrew uses the plural form, bloods, which Jewish tradition has long understood as including not only Abel himself but all the descendants he would have had. Every murder is a multiplication, a cutting off of countless lives that would have come. The earth itself, the very ground that received Adam's body in the garden, now testifies against violence.

And then we see Cain's lineage drift further away from God. By the time we reach Lamech (verses 23-24), sin has metastasized. Lamech kills a man for merely striking him, and boasts about it to his wives in a poem. He invokes the principle of measured vengeance that God had used to protect Cain, "if Cain's revenge is sevenfold, then Lamech's is seventy-sevenfold", and weaponizes it for his own ego. Sin not only spreads; it amplifies. Each generation, left to itself, escalates the cycle.

But the chapter does not end there. Verse 25 brings Seth, the replacement for Abel. And verse 26 brings a single beautiful sentence: "At that time people began to call upon the name of the LORD." Even in the depth of human degradation, even in the first generations after exile from Eden, there is a remnant, people who worship. The story of redemption is the story of this remnant, called by God, kept by God, leading through generations all the way to Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Unit 1 told us what humanity was meant to be (Genesis 1-2) and what humanity became (Genesis 3). Genesis 4 is the immediate aftermath. The covenant of works was broken, the curse was pronounced, the gospel was promised, and now we begin to see what life under those conditions actually looks like. The seed of the woman (Genesis 3:15) is still in view: Cain is rejected as the promised one, Abel is killed, but Seth is born to continue the godly line, and his son Enosh leads people to call on the name of the LORD. The line of promise will

run through Seth, then through Noah, then through Abraham, then through David, all the way to Christ. The first hint that God's redemptive plan will be preserved despite human violence appears in the very chapter where the first violence happens.

STEP 6

Application

Listen to God's warning to Cain, it is a warning to you. "Sin is crouching at the door. Its desire is for you, but you must rule over it." This is a profound psychological insight. Sin in the believer's life is not a one-time event but a persistent presence, waiting at the doorway of every heart, looking for an opportunity. The Christian life is not the absence of temptation; it is the daily ruling over sin by the Spirit's power.

Practically, where is sin crouching at your door today? Maybe it is bitterness toward someone. Maybe it is a habitual indulgence. Maybe it is anger you have been nursing. Maybe it is comparison or envy or the slow drift away from prayer. The point is not to be paranoid, it is to be honest. God spoke to Cain before the murder. He still speaks to his people before the sin. Are you listening?

And take Cain's deflection seriously. "Am I my brother's keeper?" In a world that is happy to pretend we are not responsible for each other, the Christian remembers: every person you encounter bears the image of God, and you are accountable for how you treat them. This applies to your closest family and your most distant neighbor. The blood of Abel still cries out from the ground when we forget this.

But take heart from verse 26. Even in the worst of times, "people began to call upon the name of the LORD." The remnant is always there. The line of promise is always preserved. The faithful worship of God always survives, even when the world is sliding into Lamech's violence. You are part of that continuing remnant. Today, call upon his name.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to show you where sin is crouching at your door, and tell him the truth about it.
- Confess any place you have deflected blame or refused to care for another person.
- Thank him that he is merciful even in the darkest chapters.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 3

“But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.”

GENESIS 6:8

DAY 18 · WEEK 3

Genesis 5:1-32

The genealogy of Adam, life, death, and the promise preserved

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 5:1-32 slowly. Yes, this is a genealogy, and it may feel like one of those passages that's tempting to skim. Don't. Genealogies in Scripture are theological documents. As you read, notice the repeated phrase "and he died," the curious exception in verse 24, and the way the chapter ends in suspense.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday we read about the first murder and the spread of sin from one generation to the next. Genesis 5 takes a step back and gives us the full genealogy of Adam through Noah, ten generations from creation to the flood. It is one of the most important genealogies in the Bible, and it sets up everything that comes next. This is also the first genealogy of Scripture, and it teaches us how to read all the ones that follow.

Genealogies are not filler. They are theological records. They tell us who is in the line of promise, how God's faithfulness has been transmitted from generation to generation, and how the world fits together as one story. This genealogy in particular establishes that there is an unbroken line from Adam to Noah, that humanity has been multiplying across the earth, that death has been spreading along with humanity, and that one man in particular, Enoch, escaped death by walking with God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 1 explicitly recalls Genesis 1:27: God "made him in the likeness of God. Male and female he created them, and he blessed them." The image of God survived the Fall, humanity still bears it.
2. Adam's first descendant is described differently from himself: "Adam … fathered a son in his own likeness, after his image, and named him Seth." The image of God is now

mediated through fallen humanity.

3. Each generation follows a strict formula: [Name] lived X years, fathered [Son], lived Y more years, fathered other sons and daughters, and the years of his life were Z, AND HE DIED.
4. The phrase “and he died” appears eight times. Death, the consequence promised in Genesis 2:17, has come true and is now the universal human experience.
5. Enoch is the seventh from Adam and breaks the pattern. He “walked with God, and he was not, for God took him.” He does not die.
6. Lamech (a different Lamech than Cain’s descendant) names his son Noah, saying “this one shall give us rest from our work and from the painful toil of our hands because of the ground that the LORD has cursed.”
7. The genealogy ends not with “and he died” for Noah, but with the open-ended note that he “had three sons”, Shem, Ham, and Japheth. The story is not over yet.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 5 looks like a list, but it is preaching. The whole chapter is built around a tension: the image of God in humanity, and the reality of death that now follows every human life. Both are true. The chapter holds them together and lets us feel the weight.

Verse 1 deliberately echoes Genesis 1:27. “When God created man, he made him in the likeness of God. Male and female he created them, and he blessed them when they were created.” After the Fall and after Cain’s violence, the writer wants us to remember: humanity is still in the image of God. The Fall did not erase the image. It marred it, but it did not destroy it. Every person born to Adam and Eve, including Cain, bears the image of God. And this matters because the image will run through this chapter, generation by generation, all the way to Noah and beyond.

But then verse 3 introduces a haunting modification. Seth is born, and the text says Adam “fathered a son in his own likeness, after his image.” The phrase has shifted. Adam was made in God’s image; Seth is made in Adam’s image. The image is now mediated through fallen humanity. This is the doctrine of original sin being expressed not through theological argument but through narrative shading. The image survives. But it is now passed down through people who have already inherited the corruption of the Fall. Every child born is in the image of God and in the image of fallen Adam at the same time.

Then comes the repeated rhythm of the chapter: "and he died." Eight times. Each life recorded, each life ended. The chapter is, in one sense, a long funeral. The promise of Genesis 2:17, "in the day you eat of it you shall surely die", is being slowly, generation by generation, fulfilled. Death is not just an unfortunate biological fact; it is a theological reality. It is the consequence of sin. And it is now woven into the fabric of human existence.

This is what makes Enoch's story so stunning. Verse 24: "Enoch walked with God, and he was not, for God took him." Enoch is the seventh from Adam, and seven is the number of completeness, of fullness, and he breaks the pattern. He does not die. The text does not explain how or why, but the phrase "walked with God" appears only twice in the Old Testament about an individual: about Enoch here and about Noah in Genesis 6:9. The implication is clear: there is a kind of life that escapes the universal sentence of death. There is a way of relating to God that transforms what death does to a person. Hebrews 11:5 puts it this way: "By faith Enoch was taken up so that he should not see death." Enoch is the first hint in Scripture that death is not the final word, even though death has come for everyone else, there is one who walks with God and bypasses the grave entirely.

The chapter then comes to its climax with Lamech and Noah. Lamech names his son Noah, which sounds like the Hebrew word for "rest." And he explains the name: "this one shall give us rest from our work and from the painful toil of our hands because of the ground that the LORD has cursed." Lamech is reaching back to Genesis 3:17, where the ground was cursed because of Adam's sin, and he is hoping, perhaps even prophesying, that this child will somehow lift the curse. He doesn't fully grasp what he is saying. Noah will not lift the curse permanently. But Noah will be the means by which God preserves humanity through the flood, and through Noah's line the true rest-giver will eventually come. The line of promise runs from Adam to Seth to Enosh to Enoch to Noah, and from there, all the way to Christ, who alone gives true rest to the weary.

STEP 5

Connection

Yesterday's reading showed sin spreading after the Fall, from Cain's anger to Lamech's vengeance. Today's chapter shows the bigger picture: ten generations of human history, with death claiming each one in turn. This is the world that the gospel will eventually answer. The promise of Genesis 3:15 (the offspring of the woman) is being preserved through a particular family line, Seth, Enosh, and onward to Noah, and ultimately to Abraham and David and Christ. Enoch's escape from death foreshadows the resurrection. Lamech's hope for rest through Noah foreshadows the deeper rest we have in Jesus. Even a genealogy is gospel-shaped when you know how to read it.

STEP 6

Application

The repeated phrase “and he died” is meant to land on you. Every human life that has ever been lived will end with that phrase. Yours will too. The Bible does not let you forget this, because pretending death is not coming is one of the most spiritually corrosive habits a human can have. Death is real. It is the consequence of sin. And it will claim you.

But Enoch is in this chapter for a reason. Enoch walked with God, and death did not have its way with him. The Christian message is not that death is unreal or that we should be brave about it. The Christian message is that death has been conquered by the one who walked with God perfectly, Jesus, and that those who are in him will follow him through death into life. Hebrews 11 lists Enoch among the heroes of faith because his story is a sign: there is a way of relating to God that changes what death does to you.

Today, ask yourself: am I walking with God? Not perfectly, Enoch alone is described that way among ordinary humans, but truly. Is my life a daily walk with the God who made me, redeemed me, and is sanctifying me? Or have I drifted into a religious routine that does not feel like walking with anyone? The phrase “walked with God” appears precious few times in Scripture. It is offered to you. Take it up.

And if you have lost someone, or are afraid of losing someone, or are afraid of your own death, let Genesis 5 do its work in two directions. Yes, death is real. Yes, it is coming. But the same chapter that records death also records Enoch, who walked with God and was taken. In Christ, that is the trajectory of every believer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his image still marks you, and tell him how you feel when you think about death.

Ask him to help you walk with him as Enoch did, day by day.

Thank Christ that death is not the end for those who are his.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 3

“But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.”

GENESIS 6:8

DAY 19 · WEEK 3

Genesis 6:1-22

The corruption of creation; Noah finds grace; the ark commanded

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Reading · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 6:1-22 slowly. This is one of the most sobering chapters in the Bible. It contains both the grimmest assessment of human depravity in the Old Testament and the first glimpse of God's grace toward a particular man. As you read, notice the contrast between verses 5 and 8.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday we walked through ten generations from Adam to Noah, watching death claim each generation in turn while the line of promise quietly continued. Today we arrive at the crisis point. Sin has not just spread, it has saturated. The world God called "very good" in Genesis 1 has become a world God grieves over in Genesis 6. The chapter we read today is the prelude to the flood. It is also the chapter where the word "grace" first appears in the Bible.

The chapter has several unusual features that have puzzled interpreters for centuries, the sons of God taking the daughters of men, the Nephilim, the lifespan limit of 120 years. These are real interpretive challenges, but they are not the point of the chapter. The point is this: humanity has become so corrupt that God will start over, but one man has found grace.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The chapter opens with a strange episode (verses 1-4) about the "sons of God" taking the "daughters of man" as wives. Many interpretations exist; the text itself is sparse.
2. Verse 3: "My Spirit shall not abide in man forever, for he is flesh: his days shall be 120 years." This may be a divine deadline before the flood, or a general statement on human lifespan.

3. Verse 5 is one of the bleakest assessments of humanity in the Bible: "every intention of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually."
4. Verse 6 attributes genuine emotion to God: he was "grieved" and his heart "was sorrowful." God is not impassive in the face of human sin.
5. Verse 8 is the hinge of the chapter: "But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD." The Hebrew word for "favor" here is hen, the first appearance of the word grace in Scripture.
6. Noah is described as "a righteous man, blameless in his generation. Noah walked with God." The same phrase used of Enoch.
7. The ark's dimensions are precise: 300 cubits long, 50 wide, 30 high. Roughly 450 feet by 75 feet by 45 feet.
8. God establishes a "covenant" with Noah (verse 18) before the flood comes, the first explicit use of the word covenant in the Bible.
9. The chapter ends: "Noah did this; he did all that God commanded him." Obedience born of grace.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 6 is one of the most theologically loaded chapters in the entire Bible. In just twenty-two verses, we see the depth of human sin, the genuine sorrow of God, the first mention of grace, the introduction of the word covenant, and the obedience of one man who walks with God against the entire grain of his culture.

The chapter opens with a mysterious passage (verses 1-4) about the "sons of God" who take the "daughters of man" as wives, producing offspring described as Nephilim and "mighty men of old, men of renown." Three main interpretations have been offered through church history: that the sons of God were fallen angels, that they were powerful human rulers, or that they were descendants of the godly line of Seth intermarrying with the corrupt line of Cain. The text itself is sparse, and good Christian interpreters have differed. What matters for our purposes is the result: a further escalation of human corruption that prompts God's verdict in verse 3 and his action in verses 5-7.

Verse 5 is the most devastating sentence in the Old Testament about the human condition. "The LORD saw that the wickedness of man was great in the earth, and that every intention of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually." Every intention. Of the thoughts. Of

the heart. Only evil. Continually. This is total depravity in narrative form. The doctrine of sin you read about on Day 6 is not a theological abstraction; it is what God himself saw when he looked at his creation a few generations after Adam.

And then comes one of the most surprising verses in the Old Testament. Verse 6: "And the LORD was sorry that he had made man on the earth, and it grieved him to his heart." This is not the cool, detached God of philosophy. This is a God who genuinely feels. He grieves over what humanity has become. He is sorrowful over the broken relationship with his image-bearers. We must be careful not to read this as a God who was surprised, the same Bible insists that God knows the end from the beginning. But we must also not flatten this into a metaphor. The God of the Bible has real affections, and human sin really grieves him.

Then verse 8, in the middle of the catastrophe: "But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD." The conjunction is everything. The world is drowning in evil, and God is grieving, BUT Noah found grace. The Hebrew word translated "favor" is hen, which appears here for the first time in Scripture and will run through the entire Old Testament as the language of unmerited divine kindness. Notice carefully what the text does not say. It does not say Noah earned God's favor or deserved God's favor. It says he found it. Grace, by definition, is found, not earned. And then it tells us what kind of man Noah was: righteous, blameless in his generation, walking with God. This is not the basis of his grace; it is the fruit of it. Noah's righteousness is what grace had made of him in a world where everyone else was evil.

The rest of the chapter is the introduction of a new covenant arrangement. God reveals his judgment plan to Noah, gives him precise instructions for the ark, and says: "I will establish my covenant with you" (verse 18). This is the first use of the word "covenant" (berith) in the Bible. From this point on, covenant will be the central category of biblical theology. God always relates to his people through covenant, first with Noah, then with Abraham, then with Israel at Sinai, then with David, and finally through the new covenant in Christ. Genesis 6 is where this great covenantal story begins.

The chapter ends with a single, climactic sentence: "Noah did this; he did all that God commanded him." It would have taken many decades to build the ark. The world was watching, probably mocking. There was no rain yet, Noah was building a sea-going vessel inland, on God's word alone. And he did everything God commanded. This is what faith looks like when grace meets a person: obedience that does not need to see results before it acts.

STEP 5

Connection

Yesterday's genealogy showed the line of promise being preserved through Seth and his descendants. Genesis 6 narrows the focus to one man, Noah. The doctrine of sin you encountered on Day 6 is here demonstrated in its most extreme form: every intention of the human heart was only evil continually. And the doctrine of grace, which the rest of the Bible will develop, makes its first explicit appearance: "Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD." From the very beginning of Scripture, the pattern is set, humanity in rebellion, God in patient grief, and one chosen by grace to receive what others cannot. This pattern will repeat with Abraham, with Israel, and ultimately in Christ, who alone is the truly righteous one through whom all who are in him are preserved through the judgment to come.

STEP 6

Application

Sit with verse 5 for a moment before you move on. "Every intention of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually." This is what God saw when he looked at humanity then, and it is what God still sees when he looks at humanity now apart from his grace. Not just bad behavior on the surface, but evil running all the way down to the intentions of the heart. This is not exaggeration. It is what your Maker sees.

And sit with verse 8. "But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD." Grace is the only difference between you and the world headed for judgment. Not your morality, your church attendance, your good intentions, your spiritual disciplines, your theology. Grace. God's free, unearned, unmerited choice to set his favor on you in Christ.

Today, consider three things. First, take your own sin seriously. The same evil that filled the earth in Noah's day is still in human hearts, yours included. Do not minimize what God grieves over. Second, take grace seriously. You did not find God; he found you. Whatever righteousness has been worked in your life is the fruit of grace, not its cause. Be humble about it. Third, take obedience seriously. Noah heard God's word and obeyed in a world that thought he was crazy. If you are following Christ today in ways that confuse or anger people around you, you are in good company. Build your ark. The flood is real. And Christ is the door.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you see in your own heart when you look honestly at it.

Thank him for the grace that has found you apart from any merit of your own.

Ask him for the kind of obedience Noah showed, even when it looks foolish to others.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 3

“But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.”

GENESIS 6:8

DAY 20 · WEEK 3

Genesis 7:1-8:19

The flood, judgment and preservation; God remembers Noah

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 7:1-8:19. This is the flood narrative itself, one of the longest single readings of Unit 2. Read steadily; don't get lost in the technical details of the chronology. The heart of the passage is the rhythm of judgment and preservation, and the great pivot in chapter 8:1: "But God remembered Noah."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday we saw God's verdict on the corrupt earth and his choice of Noah to be the one through whom humanity would be preserved. Today we read the flood itself. This is one of the most well-known stories in the Bible, but it is much more than a children's story about animals on a boat. Genesis 7-8 is a theological meditation on judgment and grace, on the de-creation and re-creation of the world, on God's commitment to preserve what he has made even while he judges what has gone wrong with it.

As you read, watch for the deliberate echoes of Genesis 1. The waters above and below come unbound. The breath of life is taken from creatures. Then, on the other side, the waters subside, dry land appears, the breath of life returns to creatures, and humanity emerges to be fruitful and multiply. This is not just a story about a flood. It is a story about creation itself starting over.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God's instruction in 7:1 is intimate: "Go into the ark, you and all your household, for I have seen that you are righteous before me in this generation."
2. Pairs of animals come in by twos for unclean animals, but by sevens for clean animals, anticipating Noah's later sacrifice.

3. Noah was 600 years old when the flood came (7:6). The text takes the long lifespans of Genesis 5 seriously.
4. The waters come from two directions: "the fountains of the great deep burst forth, and the windows of the heavens were opened" (7:11). This is a reversal of Genesis 1, where God separated the waters above from the waters below.
5. The rain falls for 40 days; the waters prevail for 150 days. The flood is not a brief thunderstorm; it is a sustained judgment.
6. Genesis 7:21-23 echoes Genesis 1 in reverse: every creature, every kind of life, on the land, perishes. De-creation.
7. Chapter 8:1 is the hinge: "But God remembered Noah and all the beasts and all the livestock that were with him in the ark." God does not forget the righteous in judgment.
8. God sends a "wind" (Hebrew ruach, also "spirit") over the earth, and the waters subside. This echoes Genesis 1:2.
9. Noah's first reconnaissance is a raven, then a dove. The dove returns with an olive leaf, life is returning to the earth.
10. When the family finally leaves the ark, they emerge into a world that, in many ways, mirrors the original creation.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The flood is one of the most theologically rich narratives in the Old Testament. To read it as merely a disaster story is to miss almost everything that matters. Genesis 7-8 is a story about creation, judgment, and new creation. Every detail is shaped by the larger biblical pattern, and once you see the pattern, the story becomes much more than a tale of survival.

First, the flood is a deliberate undoing of creation. Look back at Genesis 1. On Day 2, God separated the waters above from the waters below by placing the firmament between them. He made dry land appear. He populated the air with birds, the seas with fish, the land with animals. The world is a place of order, where the waters of chaos are held back so that life can flourish.

Now read Genesis 7:11 again. "The fountains of the great deep burst forth, and the windows of the heavens were opened." The waters above are no longer separated from the waters below. The firmament has been overwhelmed. The world is collapsing back into the chaotic, uninhabitable state of Genesis 1:2, "the earth was without form and void, and darkness was over the face of the deep." The flood is not just a natural disaster; it is creation reversing itself. Sin has so deeply corrupted the world that God allows the world to slide back toward

the chaos from which he originally rescued it. Verse 23 makes this explicit: every creature, every breath, every form of land-based life is "blotted out." The earth becomes, again, what it was before God spoke.

But not entirely. In the ark, a wooden box floating on the waters, a remnant of creation is preserved. One man, one family, pairs of every creature, the seeds of plant life, the breath of God in living things. The ark is a microcosm of the world, a fragment of creation rescued from the chaos. Some theologians have called it "creation in miniature." It is the means by which God preserves what he will then renew.

Then comes the most beautiful sentence in the entire narrative. Genesis 8:1: "But God remembered Noah and all the beasts and all the livestock that were with him in the ark." When the Bible says God "remembered" someone, it does not mean he had forgotten and then recalled. It means he is now acting on what he has known all along. God remembered Abraham, and brought Israel out of Egypt. God remembered Hannah, and gave her a son. God remembered his covenant, and acted to keep it. When God "remembers" Noah, it is the moment of grace breaking through judgment. The flood has done its work. Now the new creation can begin.

And the new creation echoes the first creation in beautiful, deliberate ways. A wind (ruach) blows over the waters, just as the Spirit (ruach) hovered over the waters in Genesis 1:2. The waters subside. Dry land appears. The breath of life returns to creatures. The dove brings back a green leaf, vegetation has survived. Noah and his family emerge from the ark into a world that, in its broad outlines, looks like the world God first made. The flood narrative ends not with destruction but with creation renewed.

This pattern, of de-creation through judgment and re-creation through grace, is one of the most important patterns in all of Scripture. It will reappear in the Exodus (Israel passes through the chaotic waters of the Red Sea into a new identity). It will reappear in the prophets (the exile is a kind of flood, and the return is a kind of new creation). It will reappear in the New Testament (baptism is a passage through water that pictures death and new life). And it will reach its climax at the end of Scripture (the present world is judged, and a new heavens and new earth emerge). The flood is the first major preview of how God works in history. Judgment and grace, death and resurrection, the old order undone and a new order rising. This is the pattern of the gospel itself.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 6 introduced Noah and the ark; today we see God's judgment fall and his preservation work. The pattern established here, de-creation through judgment, re-creation through grace, will run through the entire Bible. The Exodus will be a flood-like deliverance

(Israel passes through chaotic waters into a new identity). Baptism will be a flood-like ritual (the believer passes through water into new life with Christ). And the consummation of all things in Revelation will be the final undoing of the present order and the emergence of new heavens and new earth. When Peter writes that "baptism, which corresponds to this, now saves you" (1 Peter 3:21), he is making this exact connection. Noah is a type of every believer who is brought safely through judgment in the ark of God's grace.

STEP 6

Application

The flood is a sobering picture, but it is meant to comfort believers as much as it warns sinners. Two applications follow from this.

First, take judgment seriously. The God of Genesis 7 is the same God of the New Testament. He is patient, slow to anger, abundant in mercy, but he is not indifferent to evil. Peter explicitly draws the lesson in 2 Peter 3, comparing the flood that came on the ancient world to the judgment by fire that is yet to come on this present world. Do not let the patience of God become an excuse for casualness about sin. The reason the flood didn't come for the first six hundred years of Noah's life was not that God was unconcerned. It was that God was patient. Read your Bible knowing the same is true now. We are living in the long patience of God before a final judgment that will surely come.

Second, take grace seriously. When the floodwaters come, you do not need a stronger swimming stroke. You need an ark. And the ark, as 1 Peter teaches, is Christ. To be "in Christ", joined to him by faith, hidden in him, sealed in him, is to be safe through every judgment, both temporal and eternal. The wood of the ark in Noah's day prefigured the wood of the cross. The door that God himself closed on the ark prefigures the salvation God himself secures for his people. If you are in Christ, the flood has already passed over you, judgment fell on him, not on you, and you have emerged into a new creation.

Today, ask yourself: am I in the ark? Not, do I think well of Christianity, or do I attend church, or do I believe in God in general. Am I in Christ? Have I trusted him as my refuge, my safe passage through the judgment my sin deserves? If the answer is yes, then "God remembered Noah" is a promise for you. God remembers his own. He will bring you safely through every storm, including the last one. And the world that meets you on the other side will be a renewed creation, where righteousness dwells.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he judges sin and saves sinners, and that you are among the saved.

Praise Christ as the ark who carried you through judgment.

Ask him to keep both his patience and his coming judgment real to you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 3

“But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.”

GENESIS 6:8

DAY 21 · WEEK 3

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. The week you have just completed was a hinge week, closing Unit 1 and opening Unit 2. Take time today to let both arcs settle. The God who created in the beginning is the same God who showed grace to Noah.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD."

GENESIS 6:8

REST

Meditation

Genesis 6:8 is the first appearance of the word "grace" (Hebrew hen) in the Bible. The conjunction "But" is everything. The verses surrounding it describe the worst assessment of humanity in the Old Testament, "every intention of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually" (6:5). And then: BUT Noah found favor.

Notice what the verse does not say. It does not say Noah earned favor. It does not say Noah deserved favor. It says he FOUND it, and grace, by definition, is what is found, not what is achieved.

Say the verse with the conjunction loud in your mind. The "But" is the gospel's word. In a world of judgment, there is a "But." In a heart of rebellion, there is a "But." That "But" is the difference between being lost with the world and being saved by grace.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week was a pivot. You finished Unit 1 with Psalm 65, David's integrated meditation on creation and atonement, and the Unit 1 Review, anchored on Genesis 1:1. Then Unit 2 began. You met Cain, the first murderer, and heard God's warning that "sin is crouching at the door." You walked through the genealogy of Genesis 5, with the repeated phrase "and he died" broken only by Enoch, who walked with God. You met Noah in Genesis 6 and learned that grace is what is found, not earned. And you began the flood narrative in Genesis 7, watching judgment fall on a world that had refused God's patience.

The arc of the week is the arc of the gospel itself. Sin spreads. Judgment comes. But Noah, and ultimately Christ, finds favor with God, and through that one, others are preserved.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where do you see God's patience and his judgment held together in this week's readings? The first half of the week celebrated creation; the second half showed the spread of sin and the coming of judgment. Both are true at once. Where do you most need to remember God's patience this week? Where do you most need to remember his judgment?

How does Noah's grace prefigure the grace you have received in Christ? Noah did not deserve to be saved any more than the people who drowned. He found favor. Through one righteous man, his family was preserved through the flood. Through one righteous Man, you have been preserved through the judgment your sin deserved. Sit with this. What does it mean that you have found grace, not earned it?

What does it look like for you, today, to "walk with God" as Enoch did? The phrase appears only twice about individuals in the Old Testament, Enoch and Noah. Both lived in cultures sliding into wickedness. Both were marked by a different kind of life. What would it take for that to be true of you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the grace behind every "But God" in your own story.

Ask him to help you walk humbly and gratefully this week in a world that does not walk with him.

Rest in the favor he has shown you in Christ.

DAY 22 · WEEK 4

Genesis 8:20-9:29

The Noahic covenant; common grace; the rainbow sign

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Reading · 30 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 8:20-9:29 slowly. After the floodwaters recede, Noah disembarks and builds an altar. What follows is one of the most important covenant passages in the Old Testament, the Noahic Covenant, God's pledge to preserve creation, and the rainbow as its sign. The chapter also ends on a sober note about Noah himself, reminding us that sin survived the flood.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After a year on the ark, Noah and his family emerge into a renewed world. Today's reading covers what happens immediately after the flood, Noah's first act of worship, God's resolution never again to destroy the earth by water, the establishment of the Noahic Covenant, the institution of capital punishment for murder, the renewal of the dominion mandate, and a strange final episode involving Noah's drunkenness and his sons.

The Noahic Covenant is one of the most important covenants in the Bible, but also one of the most misunderstood. It is not a covenant of salvation; it is a covenant of preservation. It is God's commitment to maintain the natural order so that the larger story of redemption can unfold. Without the Noahic Covenant, there is no stable world in which Abraham can be called, Israel can be formed, or Christ can come. This covenant is the foundation of common grace, the kindness God shows to all people, not just to his chosen people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The first act after the flood is worship. Noah builds an altar and offers burnt offerings.
2. God "smelled the pleasing aroma" and resolved in his heart never again to curse the ground because of man. The change is in God's commitment to creation, not in humanity's heart.

3. Verse 21 candidly admits: “the intention of man’s heart is evil from his youth.” Human nature has not been reset by the flood.
4. Verse 22 establishes the rhythm of creation: “seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, day and night, shall not cease.” The natural world will be stable.
5. 9:1 echoes Genesis 1:28: “Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth.” Humanity is given a new beginning.
6. 9:6 grounds the prohibition of murder in the image of God: “whoever sheds the blood of man, by man shall his blood be shed, for God made man in his own image.”
7. The covenant is established with Noah AND with “every living creature”, it is universal in scope.
8. The rainbow is the sign of the covenant, a visible promise that judgment by water will not come again.
9. The chapter ends with Noah getting drunk, his nakedness exposed, and conflict among his sons, proving that human sin survived the flood.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Noahic Covenant is one of the most theologically significant moments in the Old Testament, but it is often overlooked in favor of the more familiar covenants with Abraham, Moses, and David. Yet without the Noahic Covenant, none of those later covenants could exist. This is the covenant that holds the world together so that redemption can unfold within it.

Notice first how the section begins. Noah builds an altar and offers burnt offerings. This is the first explicit act of sacrificial worship after the flood. Before God says anything about a covenant, before any blessing is given to the new humanity, Noah worships. And God responds. Verse 21 says, “When the LORD smelled the pleasing aroma, the LORD said in his heart, “I will never again curse the ground because of man.”” The atoning sacrifice is not yet what it will be in Christ, but the principle is there: worship offered in faith elicits divine favor. God responds to sacrifice with promise.

And what a promise it is. Verse 21: “Neither will I ever again strike down every living creature as I have done. While the earth remains, seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, day and night, shall not cease.” This is God’s commitment to stability. The natural world will continue. The seasons will turn. The earth will produce food. Day will

follow night. This is what theologians call common grace, the kindness God extends to the entire created order, both the righteous and the wicked, simply by sustaining the conditions of life.

Why does this matter? Because the verdict on humanity has not changed. Verse 21 admits it plainly: "the intention of man's heart is evil from his youth." The flood did not reset human nature. Noah and his family are not better than the people who died. They are saved by grace, not by superior virtue. And yet, despite humanity's continued wickedness, God commits himself to preserving the world. Why? Because he is planning something larger. The flood was a temporary judgment that prefigured the final judgment to come. But before the final judgment can come, the story of redemption must unfold. The line of Seth must continue through Noah to Abraham. The nation of Israel must be formed. The prophets must speak. Christ must come. The gospel must spread to the nations. All of that requires a stable world, with seasons and harvests and history continuing. The Noahic Covenant is what makes that possible.

The covenant is then formally established in chapter 9. It has several distinctive features. First, it is universal. Verse 9 says God makes the covenant "with you and your offspring after you, and with every living creature that is with you", every bird, animal, and human, present and future. Unlike the covenant with Abraham, which is particular to a specific people, this covenant is for all humanity and all creation. Every person who has ever lived, regardless of nation or religion, is a beneficiary of the Noahic Covenant. The food they eat, the seasons they enjoy, the air they breathe, these are gifts of common grace under this covenant.

Second, it includes the prohibition of murder, grounded in the image of God (9:6). This is the principle of the sanctity of human life. Whoever sheds human blood must answer for it, "for God made man in his own image." The reasoning is theological, not pragmatic. Murder is not just a social crime; it is an attack on God's image. This verse will become the foundation for all just systems of human government, the right to life, the responsibility to defend life, the establishment of justice systems to address violence.

Third, the covenant has a sign: the rainbow. "I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth." Every time it rains, the rainbow is meant to remind both God and humanity of this promise. Some scholars note that the Hebrew word for "bow" is the same word used for a weapon, and that God has "hung his bow" pointing upward, as if to say his weapon of judgment has been laid down. The rainbow is God's commitment, written in the sky, that judgment by water is over.

Then comes the strange and sobering closing scene. Noah, the righteous one through whom humanity was preserved, gets drunk and lies naked in his tent. His son Ham sees him and apparently mocks him. His other sons cover him without looking. When Noah wakes, he

curses Ham's son Canaan. This passage has been misused throughout church history, especially to justify slavery and racism, interpretations that have no basis in the text. The point of the episode is simpler and more painful: sin survived the flood. Even the man through whom humanity was preserved is still a sinner. Drunkenness, family dysfunction, and curses all reappear in the very first generation after the flood. The flood washed away the world's wickedness but not the wickedness in the human heart. A deeper solution will be needed.

STEP 5

Connection

Yesterday we saw the flood as judgment and the ark as preservation. Today we see the covenant that follows: God's commitment to maintain the world so that the story of redemption can unfold. The Noahic Covenant is the foundation of all common grace, every harvest, every season, every birth in every culture is a gift under this covenant. It is also the foundation on which the later covenants with Abraham, Moses, and David will be built. Without a stable world, there is no Israel, no land, no temple, no Bethlehem. And when Christ comes, he will fulfill not only the special covenants of grace but will reveal himself as the true Lord of the natural order, calming storms, multiplying food, raising the dead. The renewed creation that the Noahic Covenant points to will be fully realized in the new heavens and new earth.

STEP 6

Application

Today, recognize and respond to common grace. Every meal you eat, every breath you take, every sunrise you witness is a gift under the Noahic Covenant. God is patiently sustaining the world, including the parts of it that are still in rebellion against him, so that the gospel can reach more people, so that more sinners can be brought into the family of God. The reason your unbelieving neighbor's garden grows is the same as why yours does: God's faithfulness to the covenant he made with Noah.

This has practical implications. First, you can enjoy creation without guilt. The pleasures of food, music, beauty, friendship, work, these are gifts of common grace, given to all humanity, including you. Receive them with thanksgiving. Second, you can affirm what is good and true in the wider world without compromising your faith. When unbelievers do beautiful work, in art, science, justice, medicine, parenting, they are operating under common grace, and their work can be honored as such. Third, you can have hope for a world that often seems to be falling apart. The Noahic Covenant is still in force. God is still preserving creation. The story is not over.

And take seriously the dignity of human life. Genesis 9:6 grounds the sanctity of life in the image of God. Every human being you encounter, born and unborn, weak and strong, in your circle and outside it, bears that image. To diminish a human is to attack God's image. To honor a human is to honor God. Today, look at the people around you with this conviction. Each one is a recipient of common grace, an image-bearer of God, a person for whom Christ died. Treat them accordingly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for a gift of common grace that you rarely notice, such as the seasons, harvests, or order in the world.

Ask him to help you honor someone you meet today as an image bearer.

Thank him that his patience gives time for the gospel to reach people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 4

"I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth."

GENESIS 9:13

DAY 23 · WEEK 4

Genesis 10:1-11:32

Table of nations; Babel and the scattering; Abram introduced

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 10:1-11:32. This is the longest single reading of Unit 2, but it moves quickly because much of it is genealogy. The two chapters fit together: chapter 10 lists the nations that descend from Noah's three sons, chapter 11 explains why the nations are scattered and speak different languages. The reading ends with the introduction of Abram, setting up the next unit.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday we saw God establish the Noahic Covenant, a promise to preserve creation despite human sin. Today's reading shows that human sin has not been reset, and the consequences continue to spread. Genesis 10-11 covers the transition from the post-flood world to the calling of Abram. It is the bridge between primeval history and patriarchal history.

These two chapters are a deliberate pair. Chapter 10 (the Table of Nations) lists seventy nations descended from Noah's sons, a panoramic view of how the post-flood world filled up. Chapter 11 then circles back to explain how that scattering happened: the tower of Babel, where humanity's pride attempted to make a name for itself and was scattered by God. The order is intentional, the result before the explanation, the consequence before the cause.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Genesis 10 lists 70 nations descended from Noah's three sons: Japheth (14), Ham (30), and Shem (26). Seventy will become a significant number throughout the Bible.
2. The list is theologically loaded, these are not just family trees but the world's nations as God sees them.

3. Babel/Babylon (in the line of Cush) is highlighted in 10:8-10. The kingdom of Nimrod begins at Babel.
4. Genesis 11:1 makes a striking claim: "the whole earth had one language and the same words." This is the situation before the scattering.
5. Humanity gathers on the plain of Shinar (the same region as Babel) and decides: "let us build ourselves a city and a tower with its top in the heavens, and let us make a name for ourselves."
6. Note the verbs: "let us build… let us make a name." Humanity attempts what only God can rightly do, establish itself and make a name.
7. God "comes down" to see the tower, language of divine condescension, perhaps with a hint of irony at humanity's tiny achievement.
8. God confuses their language so they cannot understand one another. The result is the scattering of the nations.
9. Genesis 11:10-26 is the second post-flood genealogy, narrowing from all nations down to Shem's line, all the way to Terah and Abram.
10. The reading ends with Terah's family in Haran, and Abram set up for the great call that opens the next unit.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 10 and 11 belong together as a single theological unit. They tell us how the world we live in came to be, a world of many nations, many languages, scattered across the globe, and they tell us why. The two chapters together teach us about the unity and diversity of humanity, about the perennial human temptation to self-aggrandizement, and about how God's redemptive plan narrows down to one family in preparation for the next stage of the story.

Genesis 10, sometimes called the Table of Nations, is unique in ancient literature. No other ancient civilization produced a document like it, a genealogical map of the entire known world, organized around three brothers and seventy descendants. The number seventy is significant. It will reappear in the seventy elders who go up with Moses (Exodus 24), the seventy who descend to Egypt with Jacob (Genesis 46:27), and the seventy disciples Jesus sends out in Luke 10. The implication is that God's view of "the nations" is comprehensive but not chaotic. There is order, even in a scattered world.

But Genesis 10 also contains a quiet hint of trouble. In verses 8-10, we are told that Nimrod, a descendant of Ham, became "a mighty hunter before the LORD," and that "the beginning of his kingdom was Babel, Erech, Accad, and Calneh, in the land of Shinar." Babel, and the land of Shinar, will appear again in chapter 11 as the place where humanity organizes itself against God. Nimrod is the first empire-builder in the Bible, and his domain is the same domain that will become Babylon, the great archetypal enemy of God's people throughout Scripture. The shadow is already falling.

Then chapter 11 explains how the scattering of the nations actually happened. Verse 1 sets the scene: "the whole earth had one language and the same words." This is the pre-Babel world, unified, with shared communication. Then humanity migrates to the plain of Shinar and proposes a building project. The language is striking. "Let us build ourselves a city and a tower with its top in the heavens, and let us make a name for ourselves." Three verbs in one sentence: let us build, let us make a name, lest we be dispersed. Each of these is a usurpation. Humanity is meant to be fruitful and multiply across the earth (Genesis 1:28; 9:1), but they are gathering in one place. Humanity is meant to receive a name from God (Adam was named by God; Eve was named by Adam, but in submission to God's word), but they are making a name for themselves. Humanity is meant to fill the earth, but they are trying to avoid being dispersed.

The tower itself is a profound theological symbol. A tower "with its top in the heavens" is an assault on the boundary between heaven and earth. It is an attempt to ascend to where God dwells, on humanity's own terms, by humanity's own engineering. It is the sin of Eden in architectural form, "you will be like God", repeated on a civilizational scale. And the motive is pride: "let us make a name for ourselves." The reason God's people make a name for themselves at all in Scripture is when God gives them a name. To make a name for yourself is to claim what only God can give.

God's response is gracious irony. "And the LORD came down to see the city and the tower" (verse 5). The tower whose top was in the heavens is so small that God has to come down to see it. The pride of humanity is reduced to its true scale. And then God acts. He confuses their language, and they cannot understand one another, and the project collapses. Humanity is scattered across the face of the earth, which is what they were supposed to do all along.

But the chapter does not end in judgment. Verses 10-26 narrow the focus down. From all the nations of chapter 10, we are now tracing one line, Shem's descendants. From Shem to Eber (whose name probably gives us "Hebrew"), from Eber to Peleg, all the way to Terah, who fathers Abram, Nahor, and Haran. The genealogy is selective and deliberate. The whole

world has been mapped in chapter 10. The whole world has been scattered in chapter 11. And now the redemptive story is going to narrow to one man, Abram, through whom all the scattered nations of the earth will eventually be blessed.

This narrowing is not a contraction of God's purposes. It is the strategy by which his purposes will reach all the nations. God will not save the world by addressing all nations equally. He will save the world by calling one man, forming one nation, fulfilling his promises through one descendant, who will then bring blessing back to all the families of the earth. The pattern is set here in Genesis 11 and will define the rest of the biblical story.

STEP 5

Connection

Unit 2 has traced the trajectory of sin in the post-Eden, post-Fall world. Genesis 4 showed it in one family, Cain and Abel. Genesis 5 showed it as the universal experience of death across generations. Genesis 6-9 showed it overflowing into corruption, then judgment, then preserved by covenant. Today's reading shows it on a civilizational scale, humanity united in rebellion at Babel, scattered by God, and yet through it all, the line of promise is preserved. The genealogy that ends Genesis 11 sets up Unit 3 perfectly: out of the scattered nations, God will call one man, Abram. Through him, the blessing will eventually come to "all the families of the earth" (Genesis 12:3). Pentecost in Acts 2 will be the great reversal of Babel, when the gospel is preached, the languages are heard, and the nations begin to come back to God through Christ.

STEP 6

Application

The temptation of Babel is not ancient. It is contemporary. "Let us build ourselves a city... and make a name for ourselves." Humans still want to make a name for themselves. Still want to ascend to heaven on their own terms. Still want to gather in unified rebellion against the boundaries God has established. The names of the projects change. The technologies change. The slogans change. But the impulse is the same.

Examine your own ambitions today. What names are you trying to make for yourself? In your career, your relationships, your social presence, your accomplishments, where are you trying to ascend to a place where you can stand without need of God? The Christian life is not about achieving namelessness; it is about receiving the name God gives. Abram becomes Abraham. Jacob becomes Israel. Simon becomes Peter. Saul becomes Paul. And every believer is given the name of Christ. The name you are seeking is already being offered, freely. Let go of the tower.

There is also a positive application. The scattering of Babel was a judgment, but it was also a strategy. By dispersing humanity, God set up the long story by which the gospel would one day reach every nation. At Pentecost, the curse of Babel was beginning to be reversed, people from every nation under heaven heard the gospel in their own language. The Great Commission picks up where Babel left off: go to all the nations, baptize them, teach them. The diversity of the nations is not a problem to be undone; it is a stage on which the glory of God's redemption can be displayed.

If you are part of a church today, you are part of the answer to Babel. The blood of Christ has begun to do what scattered languages could never undo, bring people together not into a single tower of pride but into a single body of grace. Pray for the gospel to keep doing this. And live in the awareness that your role, however small it feels, is part of the great reversal that began at Pentecost and will be consummated when the nations gather around the throne of the Lamb.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess any tower you have been building to make a name for yourself.
- Ask him to help you rest in the name he gives you in Christ.
- Pray for people from nations and languages that are not yours, that they would be gathered in.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 4

"I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth."

GENESIS 9:13

DAY 24 · WEEK 4

Psalm 36:5-12

Steadfast love reaches to the heavens, common grace celebrated

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 36:5-12 slowly, twice. This is the second half of Psalm 36, the first half describes the wicked, the second half praises God's steadfast love. Today's portion is the praise section. Read it as the appropriate response to all we have seen in Genesis 4-11: in a world of human wickedness, God's love reaches to the heavens.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

We have just spent six days walking through the bleakest portion of the early Bible, Cain's murder of Abel, the universal spread of death in Genesis 5, the corruption of all flesh in Genesis 6, the flood, the post-flood failure of Noah, and finally the pride of Babel. The human story so far has not been encouraging. We have seen humanity in rebellion at every scale: individual, family, civilization, world.

Today's psalm reminds us that the bleakness of human sin is not the last word. God's steadfast love is bigger. His faithfulness reaches to the clouds. His righteousness is like the mountains. His justice is like the great deep. In a world of Cains and Lamechs and Babels, God's love runs deeper than human evil ever can.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 5: "Your steadfast love, O LORD, extends to the heavens, your faithfulness to the clouds." The vertical scale of God's love matches the vertical attempts at Babel, but God truly reaches the heavens.
2. Verse 6: God's righteousness is "like the mountains of God," his judgments "like the great deep." The natural world is the measure of his moral attributes.

3. Verse 6 ends with a beautiful inclusion: “man and beast you save, O LORD.” Common grace is in view, God’s care extends to all creatures.
4. Verse 7: “How precious is your steadfast love, O God! The children of mankind take refuge in the shadow of your wings.” Image of a mother bird sheltering her young.
5. Verses 8-9 use feast and water imagery: “they feast on the abundance of your house… For with you is the fountain of life; in your light do we see light.”
6. Verse 9 contains one of the most theologically rich lines in the Psalms: “in your light do we see light.” Knowledge of God comes through God himself.
7. The psalm closes with a prayer that God will preserve his people from the wicked and ensure the downfall of evildoers, fitting after the chapters we just read.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 36:5-12 is one of the most expansive descriptions of God’s love in the entire Psalter. After the first half of the psalm describes the wicked, those who flatter themselves, who plot evil on their beds, who do not reject what is evil, the second half lifts our eyes upward to behold something greater than human wickedness: the steadfast love of God himself.

Notice the vertical movement of verse 5: “Your steadfast love, O LORD, extends to the heavens, your faithfulness to the clouds.” Right after we have just read about humanity building a tower whose “top is in the heavens” (Genesis 11:4), this psalm announces that God’s love is what actually reaches the heavens. The Babel-builders tried to make their name reach to the clouds. They failed. But God’s faithfulness already reaches there. The human pride that tried to bridge heaven and earth from below is unnecessary, because God’s love has already bridged it from above.

The next image is equally striking. “Your righteousness is like the mountains of God, your judgments are like the great deep.” God’s character is given the scale of creation itself. His righteousness is mountainous, solid, immovable, towering. His judgments are deep, beyond human plumbing, profound, unsearchable. We do not measure God’s morality by our own intuitions. We measure our intuitions by his unchanging character. And both of these, the heights of his love and the depths of his judgments, are realities we can stake our lives on.

Then verse 6 ends with a sentence that lands with extra weight after the readings of Unit 2: “Man and beast you save, O LORD.” Save. The Hebrew word is yasha, the same root from which we get the name Yeshua, Jesus. God saves not only humans but animals. He cares for all his creatures. After the flood narrative, where animals were taken into the ark, after the Noahic Covenant which explicitly includes “every living creature”, this verse rings with theological weight. God’s saving care extends across all his creation.

Verse 7 introduces one of the most tender images in the Psalter. “How precious is your steadfast love, O God! The children of mankind take refuge in the shadow of your wings.” This is the image of a mother bird sheltering her chicks under her outstretched wings. Jesus will use this very image later in his lament over Jerusalem (Matthew 23:37): “How often would I have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you would not!” The God of Psalm 36 is the God of Christ, the one who longs to gather his people under his protection.

Then comes a feast. Verse 8: “They feast on the abundance of your house, and you give them drink from the river of your delights.” This is hospitality. God does not merely tolerate his people; he feeds them lavishly. The “river of your delights” (Hebrew Eden, the very word!) recalls the garden of Eden and its rivers of life. What was lost in the Fall is offered again to those who take refuge in God. The original garden has not been forgotten; it is being recovered for those who come to him.

Then verse 9 lands as one of the most theologically dense lines in all of Scripture: “For with you is the fountain of life; in your light do we see light.” Both parts of this verse contain entire theologies. Life itself flows from God, he is the fountain, the source, the spring. Apart from him, there is no life. And we see light only by his light. Knowledge of God is not human achievement; it is divine self-revelation. We do not climb up to see God; he shines down so that we can see him. This is the doctrine of revelation in eight words.

The psalm closes with a prayer that God will continue his steadfast love to those who know him, and that the wicked will not have the final word. This is exactly the right prayer after Unit 2. We have seen the wicked, Cain, the world before the flood, the Babel-builders. We have seen God’s patience and grace. And now we pray, with the psalmist, that God’s steadfast love will continue, and that the trajectory of the wicked will end in judgment, while the trajectory of those who know God will end in light.

STEP 5

Connection

Six days ago we read about Cain, whose anger was not ruled. Today’s psalm describes those who “have no fear of God before their eyes” (the first half of Psalm 36, not in our reading), Cain’s spiritual descendants. But after the description of wickedness comes the description of God’s love, and it is overwhelming. After all we have read in Unit 2, the spread of sin, the flood, Babel, this psalm is the appropriate worship. Yes, the world is full of human wickedness. But God’s love reaches to the heavens. His faithfulness to the clouds. His righteousness like mountains. His judgments like the great deep. The God of common grace, who preserves creation under the Noahic Covenant, is the God whose love is bigger than every evil we have witnessed.

STEP 6

Application

The psalmist's response to wickedness is not despair, and not vengeance. It is to lift his eyes to the steadfast love of God. This is a learnable habit. When you read the news, when you face conflict in relationships, when you see injustice that grieves you, you have a choice. You can let your soul shrink down to the size of the wickedness in front of you, or you can lift your eyes to the love of God that reaches to the heavens. The wicked are real. So is God's steadfast love. Choose which one you will let define your day.

Practically, take verse 9 with you today. "In your light do we see light." We do not see clearly by our own effort. We see by God's light. This applies to almost every dimension of the Christian life. We do not understand Scripture by our own intelligence; we understand it by the illumination of the Spirit. We do not pray well by our own ability; we pray well by the Spirit who teaches us to cry "Abba, Father." We do not love well by our own willpower; we love well by the love of God poured into our hearts. The light is his, given to us. Receive it.

And consider the image of taking refuge in the shadow of God's wings. In a world where everything feels exposed, where reputations can be destroyed by a single tweet, where lives can be unraveled by a single accident, God offers shadow. Hiddenness. Protection. The Christian is not asked to be impressive in the world's eyes. The Christian is invited to be hidden under God's wings, fed at his table, given to drink from his river. This is your inheritance in Christ. Today, claim it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for steadfast love that is bigger than the wickedness you see, including your own.

Ask him to hide you in the shadow of his wings today.

Pray that in his light you would see yourself, the world, and Christ more truly.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 4

"I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth."

GENESIS 9:13

DAY 25 · WEEK 4

Psalm 33:10-22

The LORD frustrates the plans of nations, sovereign over Babel

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 33:10-22 slowly, twice. This is the second half of Psalm 33, earlier in this plan we read verses 1-9, which praised God for creation. Today's portion turns to God's sovereignty over the nations and his particular care for his people. It is the perfect Psalm after the scattering of Babel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Two days ago we read the tower of Babel, humanity united in pride against God, scattered in confusion. Today's psalm gives us the divine perspective on the affairs of nations. From God's vantage point, the schemes of humans are nothing. The plans of kings come to nothing apart from his will. And yet, the God who frustrates the proud also watches faithfully over those who fear him. This psalm is the right meditation after the events of Genesis 11.

We read Psalm 33:1-9 on an earlier day in this plan. That section celebrated creation by God's word. Today's half completes the meditation by showing that the same God who created by his word governs history by his sovereignty.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 10: "The LORD brings the counsel of the nations to nothing; he frustrates the plans of the peoples." Babel is exactly this, counsel of nations brought to nothing.
2. Verse 11: "The counsel of the LORD stands forever, the plans of his heart to all generations." Contrast, human plans fail, God's plans endure.
3. Verse 12: "Blessed is the nation whose God is the LORD, the people whom he has chosen as his heritage!" Election language, God chooses a people.

4. Verses 13-15: God looks down from heaven and sees ALL the children of man. He fashions their hearts. He observes their deeds.
5. Verses 16-17: “The king is not saved by his great army… the war horse is a false hope.” Military power is unreliable apart from God.
6. Verse 18: “Behold, the eye of the LORD is on those who fear him, on those who hope in his steadfast love.” His attention is fixed on his people.
7. Verse 19: God delivers from death and keeps alive in famine. Common life-preservation under the Noahic Covenant.
8. Verses 20-22 close in waiting: “Our soul waits for the LORD; he is our help and our shield.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 33:10-22 picks up where the first half left off. Verses 1-9 praised God for creating by his word. Now the focus shifts to God’s sovereign rule over history, and to his particular care for the people who fear him.

Verse 10 lands with extra weight after our reading of Genesis 11. “The LORD brings the counsel of the nations to nothing; he frustrates the plans of the peoples.” Babel is the paradigm example of this verse in action. Humanity united in counsel, “let us build a tower”, and God brought the counsel to nothing in a single act of language-confusion. The verse is not nostalgic about Babel; it is descriptive of God’s ongoing sovereignty. Every empire that has ever risen against God has eventually come to nothing. Babylon. Assyria. Persia. Rome. Every modern attempt to construct human autonomy apart from God ends in the same way, sooner or later, in confusion and scattering.

But the verse is followed immediately by its inverse. Verse 11: “The counsel of the LORD stands forever, the plans of his heart to all generations.” The same sovereignty that frustrates human plans establishes God’s plans. History is not a contest between God’s purposes and humanity’s purposes that might go either way. God’s plans are unshakeable. They will endure when every empire has fallen. This is not a depressing verse for the believer; it is the most hope-filled verse imaginable. The plans of God’s heart, including his plan to redeem you, to keep you, to bring you safely home, will stand forever.

Verse 12 then makes a particular claim: “Blessed is the nation whose God is the LORD, the people whom he has chosen as his heritage!” In Old Testament context, this referred primarily to Israel. But in the New Testament, the apostle Peter applies this language to the

church: “you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession” (1 Peter 2:9). The church is now the people whom God has chosen as his heritage. The blessing of verse 12 belongs to every believer who is in Christ.

Verses 13-15 give us the vantage point of the King of heaven. “The LORD looks down from heaven; he sees all the children of man; from where he sits enthroned he looks out on all the inhabitants of the earth.” Nothing escapes his gaze. Babel’s tower was not impressive to him; the present rebellions of contemporary humanity are not impressive to him either. From his throne, he sees everything, knows everything, fashions every heart, observes every deed. This is sobering for the wicked. It is comforting for the faithful. You are seen. By the God who matters.

Then verses 16-17 deliver one of the great political theology passages of the Psalter. “The king is not saved by his great army; a warrior is not delivered by his great strength. The war horse is a false hope for salvation, and by its great might it cannot rescue.” This is a stunning claim in the ancient Near East. Every nation around Israel boasted in its military strength. Israel was tiny by comparison. And the psalmist says, plainly: military might does not save. Armies are not the deciding factor. War horses are not the source of victory. The Lord is. Whatever strength a king or nation has is temporary, contingent, and ultimately useless against the will of God.

Then verse 18 brings us to the warm center of the psalm. “Behold, the eye of the LORD is on those who fear him, on those who hope in his steadfast love.” The same God whose eye sweeps over the whole earth has his eye fixed in particular on those who fear him. His attention is not divided thinly across humanity. It is concentrated on his people. Those who fear him, who hope in his steadfast love, they are watched, kept, loved with focused attention.

And what does God do for them? Verse 19: “that he may deliver their soul from death and keep them alive in famine.” This is the Noahic Covenant language at the personal level. God preserves life. He delivers from death. He keeps his people alive through times when others perish. This is true at the temporal level (sometimes God protects believers from physical disasters), and it is supremely true at the spiritual level (the eternal life he gives in Christ delivers from the second death and keeps the believer alive forever).

The psalm closes with a posture of waiting. “Our soul waits for the LORD; he is our help and our shield. For our heart is glad in him, because we trust in his holy name. Let your steadfast love, O LORD, be upon us, even as we hope in you.” The Christian life is, in large part, a posture of waiting, waiting for promises to be fulfilled, for prayers to be answered, for the final consummation of all things. But it is not anxious waiting. It is glad waiting, trusting waiting, hoping waiting. We wait because we know whom we are waiting for.

STEP 5

Connection

Today's psalm is the divine perspective on yesterday's reading. Where Genesis 11 showed us Babel from the ground, humans plotting, building, getting scattered, Psalm 33 shows us Babel from heaven. God sees the counsel of the nations and brings it to nothing. His own counsel stands forever. And while he scatters the proud, his eye remains on those who fear him. The psalm anticipates everything Unit 3 will develop. God is about to bring the counsel of his heart to bear in human history by calling one man, Abram. From Abram will come Israel, the "nation whose God is the LORD" (verse 12), the heritage God has chosen. And from Israel will come Christ, in whom the chosen heritage now includes every nation that believes.

STEP 6

Application

Live today in the light of God's sovereignty. Two specific applications follow.

First, do not be intimidated by what the world calls power. The psalm is candid: the king is not saved by his great army. The war horse is a false hope. The political powers that loom over your news feed, the cultural forces that seem unstoppable, the corporate behemoths that shape your daily life, none of them is ultimate. God brings the counsel of the nations to nothing. He does it on his own timeline, often invisibly, but he does it. Live as someone who knows this. Do not give your fear to anything that God can dismantle with a thought.

Second, take the comfort of verse 18 into your day. "The eye of the LORD is on those who fear him." If you fear God, if you love him, trust him, follow him, then his eye is on you in particular. Not as a generalized providence that covers everyone equally, but as the focused attention of a Father who has chosen you as his heritage. You are seen. You are watched over. You are not lost in the crowd of humanity. Whatever you are facing today, the eye of the LORD is on you.

And take the posture of verses 20-22. Wait. Trust. Hope. Receive God's steadfast love. The Christian life is not a sprint to fix everything that is wrong. It is a long walk of waiting on the LORD who is your help and your shield. Be glad in him today. Trust his holy name. Let his steadfast love be upon you, even as you hope in him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what feels out of control in your life or the world right now.

Thank him that nothing escapes his sight and nothing thwarts his purposes.

Ask him for a soul that waits for him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 4

"I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth."

GENESIS 9:13

DAY 26 · WEEK 4

Psalm 9

I will give thanks; God judges the world in righteousness

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 9 slowly, twice. This is a longer Psalm, twenty verses, but it moves quickly. As you read, notice how the Psalm alternates between thanksgiving for God's past faithfulness and prayer about God's future judgment. It is a fitting Psalm to close out the meditations of Unit 2.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

We are at the end of Unit 2. We have walked through the spread of sin in the post-flood world, the catastrophe of the flood itself, the Noahic Covenant of preservation, and the pride and scattering of Babel. Throughout, we have seen a particular pattern: human evil is real, judgment is real, but God's faithfulness to preserve his people and his world is also real. Today's psalm gathers up many of these threads in worship.

Psalm 9 is attributed to David, sung "to the tune of Muth-labben," the meaning of which is uncertain. The psalm celebrates God's righteous judgment of the nations and his vindication of the oppressed. It is the perfect Old Testament prayer for those who have just been reading about humanity in rebellion.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with whole-hearted thanksgiving: "I will give thanks to the LORD with my whole heart; I will recount all of your wonderful deeds."
2. Verses 4-6 describe past acts of divine judgment: God has rebuked the nations, the wicked have perished, their cities have been overthrown.
3. Verse 7 is theological: "The LORD sits enthroned forever; he has established his throne for justice." Justice is built into the throne itself.

4. Verse 8: “He judges the world with righteousness; he judges the peoples with uprightness.” Universal scope, all nations, with perfect justice.
5. Verse 9: “The LORD is a stronghold for the oppressed, a stronghold in times of trouble.” Justice for the wicked is mercy for the oppressed.
6. Verse 10: “Those who know your name put their trust in you, for you, O LORD, have not forsaken those who seek you.” Knowing God’s name leads to trust.
7. Verses 11-12 are about declaring God’s deeds to the nations, taking the message outward.
8. Verses 15-16: The wicked are caught in the nets they set for others. Justice is poetic, sin returns on itself.
9. Verse 17: “The wicked shall return to Sheol, all the nations that forget God.” Forgetting God has eschatological consequences.
10. Verse 18 is the great hinge: “For the needy shall not always be forgotten, and the hope of the poor shall not perish forever.”
11. The psalm closes with a prayer for God to arise and judge, “Let the nations know that they are but men.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 9 is a song about the justice of God, sung by someone who has seen enough of human wickedness to want it. It is honest about evil and confident about God’s response. It is exactly the right psalm after Unit 2.

The psalm opens with thanksgiving, but notice what David is thankful for. He is thankful for God’s “wonderful deeds.” And as you read on, those wonderful deeds include God’s acts of judgment against the wicked. This sets a tone that may feel strange to modern ears. We tend to be uncomfortable with celebrating divine judgment. But the psalmist is not uncomfortable. To him, God’s judgment of the wicked is something worth singing about, because it means the oppressed are vindicated, the world is being put right, and the king of justice is on his throne.

Verse 7 captures the heart of the psalm’s theology: “The LORD sits enthroned forever; he has established his throne for justice.” Justice is not a peripheral concern for God. It is built into the foundation of his kingship. He does not occasionally judge; he reigns from a throne whose central purpose is judgment. And the next verse expands the scope: “He judges the world with righteousness; he judges the peoples with uprightness.” This is universal. Every nation. Every person. All judged by God’s perfect standard, in his perfect time.

But here is where the psalm reframes everything. The judgment of the wicked is the salvation of the oppressed. Verse 9: "The LORD is a stronghold for the oppressed, a stronghold in times of trouble." The same God who is terrifying to the proud is a refuge for the broken. The same justice that frightens the comfortable is good news for the abused, the forgotten, the powerless. If you are tempted to wish God were less just, ask yourself what you are wishing for. A God who does not judge is a God who does not care about the oppressed. A God who never punishes is a God who never vindicates. The justice of God is the hope of the poor.

Verse 10 introduces a tender phrase: "Those who know your name put their trust in you." Knowing God's name is biblical shorthand for knowing God personally. To know his name is to know who he really is, his character, his promises, his commitments. And to know him is to trust him. People do not trust strangers. They trust people they know. The reason some people do not trust God is that they do not yet know him. The reason believers can trust him even in dark times is that they have come to know his name.

Then comes the great social vision of the psalm in verses 11-12 and 16-18. The God who judges remembers the blood of the oppressed. He does not forget the cry of the afflicted. The needy will not always be forgotten. The hope of the poor will not perish forever. These verses are the seedbed of the entire prophetic tradition in the Old Testament, where the prophets thunder against injustice on God's behalf. They are also the foundation of the church's commitment to the poor and the oppressed. The God we worship is the God who hears the cry of the needy.

There is also a fascinating image of poetic justice in verses 15-16. "The nations have sunk in the pit that they made; in the net that they hid, their own foot has been caught. The LORD has made himself known; he has executed judgment; the wicked are snared in the work of their own hands." Evil has a way of consuming those who practice it. The traps set for others entangle their setters. The systems built to oppress eventually collapse on those who built them. This is not karma in an impersonal sense; it is the moral grain of the universe set by God. Sin destroys those who indulge it. The wicked are not so much punished by God as left to be destroyed by their own choices.

The psalm closes with a prayer: "Arise, O LORD! Let not man prevail; let the nations be judged before you! Put them in fear, O LORD! Let the nations know that they are but men!" This is a strong prayer, and it should feel strong in our mouths. It is a prayer for God to be God, for him to step in, judge the nations, and remind them of their creatureliness. After reading about Babel, this prayer feels exactly right. The nations have forgotten that they are but men. We pray that God will remind them.

STEP 5

Connection

Unit 2 has shown us human sin at every scale, individual (Cain), familial (Noah's drunkenness), civilizational (Babel). Psalm 9 is the appropriate prayer in response. We have seen the wicked, and we cry out for justice. We have seen God's preservation through covenant, and we give thanks. We have seen the oppressed of every era, those crushed by Lamechs and Nimrods, and we trust that God will not forget them. The psalm anticipates everything Unit 3 will develop: God arises, the nations are judged, and one man (Abram) is called to be the beginning of God's plan to bless the very nations that have rebelled against him.

STEP 6

Application

Today, let this Psalm shape three things in you.

First, your view of God's justice. Many modern Christians have unconsciously absorbed the idea that God's judgment is embarrassing or harsh, something to apologize for. The psalmist shows us a different posture. Divine justice is something to thank God for. It is the foundation of his throne. It is the hope of the oppressed. If you struggle with the doctrine of God's wrath, read this Psalm and ask why the people of God have sung it joyfully for three thousand years. The answer is that they knew what we sometimes forget: justice is mercy when it is directed at oppression.

Second, your view of God's care for the oppressed. The God of Psalm 9 hears the cry of the afflicted. He does not forget the blood of the oppressed. The needy shall not always be forgotten. This commits the believer to active concern for those who suffer in this world. If God remembers the oppressed, his people cannot pretend not to see them. Today, ask yourself: who in your life is being forgotten? In your church, your neighborhood, your city, your family? The God you worship sees them. Let your eyes see them too.

Third, your view of your own situation. If you are facing injustice today, at work, in your family, in your community, Psalm 9 is your prayer. The LORD is a stronghold for the oppressed. He has not forsaken those who seek him. The traps set for you will, in God's time, fall on the heads of those who set them. You do not have to retaliate, because justice is not your job. Justice is God's throne. Trust him. Wait for him. Sing his praise. And know that the same God who judged Babel will, in his time, vindicate every faithful sufferer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give thanks to God with your whole heart, naming something he has done.

Ask him to help you trust him more fully as you know him better.

Pray for someone who is poor or oppressed, and ask what he might have you do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 4

"I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth."

GENESIS 9:13

DAY 27 · WEEK 4

Review and Reflection

Unit 2 review, Common Grace & the Noahic Covenant

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD."
>
> GENESIS 6:8

REST

Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and reflection on what you have learned in Unit 2.

Begin by memorizing the verse above if you have not already. Genesis 6:8 is the hinge of the entire Noah narrative. Surrounding this single sentence is the bleakest assessment of humanity in the Old Testament (verse 5: "every intention of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually") and the announcement of the coming flood (verse 7). But in the middle of judgment, this one verse stands out: "But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD."

This is the first occurrence of the Hebrew word hen, favor, or grace, in the Bible. Everything that the New Testament will say about salvation by grace is anticipated here. Noah did not earn favor. He did not negotiate for favor. He found it. Grace, by definition, is what is found, not what is achieved.

Say this verse aloud several times today. Notice the conjunction: "But Noah found favor." That "but" is everything. In a world of judgment, there is a "but." In a heart of rebellion, there is a "but." That "but" is the difference between being lost with the world and being preserved by grace. The same "but" applies to every believer in Christ, in a world that is, in the language of Romans 1, under the wrath of God, there is a "but" for those who have found favor through faith in Jesus. "But God, being rich in mercy…" (Ephesians 2:4). The story of salvation always turns on that small word.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 2 you have traveled through Genesis 4 to 11, the early chapters of humanity after the Fall. The unit began with Cain's murder of Abel, the first violence in human history, and the warning that "sin is crouching at the door." It then moved through the genealogy of Adam to Noah, where ten generations were punctuated by the repeated phrase "and he died", except for Enoch, who walked with God and was not. The pre-flood corruption of humanity was so total that God resolved to start over, but Noah found favor.

The flood narrative was one of the longer readings of the unit: judgment by water, the ark as a microcosm of creation, the de-creation and re-creation of the world, the great hinge of "God remembered Noah." Then came the Noahic Covenant, God's pledge to preserve creation, including "man and beast," under the sign of the rainbow. This is the foundation of common grace.

The unit's final reading was Genesis 10-11: the Table of Nations showing how the post-flood world filled up, and the tower of Babel showing how quickly human pride re-asserted itself. Humanity tried to make a name for itself; God scattered them. But the chapter ended with the line of Shem narrowing down to Terah and Abram, setting up Unit 3.

The Psalms then taught us how to respond to all of this. Psalm 36 lifted our eyes to God's steadfast love that reaches to the heavens, bigger than every wickedness we had witnessed. Psalm 33 reminded us that God brings the counsel of the nations to nothing while his own counsel stands forever. And Psalm 9 sang the justice of God who hears the cry of the oppressed and reigns from a throne of judgment.

The big theological lessons of this unit are these: Sin spreads from generation to generation, but the line of promise is preserved. Judgment is real and is sometimes severe, but it is always paired with mercy for the faithful. The Noahic Covenant is God's commitment to maintain the world as a stage on which redemption can unfold. Common grace touches every life and every culture, regardless of belief. And underneath every story of rebellion, God is patiently moving toward Abram, through whom blessing will eventually come to all the families of the earth.

REFLECT

Review Questions

How does the story of Cain and Abel show the nature and spread of sin?

Revisit Genesis 4. Sin is shown crouching at the door, an active force seeking to consume. Cain refuses to rule over it, and the result is the first murder. Notice how quickly sin escalates: by Lamech (verses 23-24), the cycle of vengeance has multiplied seventy-sevenfold. Sin is not just an individual failure; it is a multiplying force that ruptures families, communities, and generations. Write a few sentences in your own words about what Genesis 4 teaches you about how sin works.

What is the Noahic covenant, and who does it include?

Read Genesis 9:8-17 again. The Noahic Covenant is God's promise never again to destroy the earth by flood. Notice its scope: it is made with Noah and his descendants, but also with "every living creature" on the earth. This is the most universal of God's covenants. It is also the foundation of common grace, every harvest, every season, every birth in every culture is a gift under this covenant. What does it tell you about God that he extends this covenant to all of creation, even to people who do not believe in him?

What does the tower of Babel reveal about human nature and God's purposes?

Look at Genesis 11:1-9. Humans gathered together to "make a name for ourselves" and to build a tower "with its top in the heavens." Three sins converge in this story: pride (making a name), idolatry (replacing God's name with their own), and disobedience (gathering rather than filling the earth). God's response, confusion of language and scattering, is judgment, but also redemption strategy. Through scattering, God sets up the long story by which the gospel will eventually reach every nation. The reversal begins at Pentecost. How does this shape the way you see the world today?

How does common grace differ from saving grace?

Common grace is the kindness God extends to all humanity, regardless of belief, the rain that falls on the just and the unjust, the harvests, the seasons, the beauty in human cultures, the goodness in human relationships. It is grounded in the Noahic Covenant. Saving grace is the particular grace by which God redeems his elect through Christ, the grace by which Noah found favor in God's eyes, and by which every believer is brought into the family of God. Both are gifts. Both are unearned. But common grace preserves the world; saving grace transforms hearts. Sit with the distinction. How does understanding the difference help you appreciate both the beauty in the unbelieving world and the particular wonder of your own salvation?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his patience with the world and with you, in your own words.

Thank him for the line of promise that leads to Christ.

Ask him to keep what you learned in this unit alive in how you live.

DAY 28 · WEEK 4

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 2 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. Yesterday you completed the Unit 2 review; today closes the week with rest. Take time to let both the doctrinal weight of Unit 2 and the rhythm of weekly Sabbath settle into your heart.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth."

GENESIS 9:13

REST

Meditation

The rainbow is the sign of the Noahic Covenant, God's promise never to destroy the earth by flood again. In the ancient Near East, a bow was a weapon. Here, God hangs his bow in the sky with the string pointing AWAY from the earth, as if to say: my weapon of judgment has been laid down.

Every rainbow you have ever seen is a reminder of this covenant, and a promise that God's judgment is not the last word for his world. The covenant is universal in scope, made with "every living creature" on earth. Every harvest, every sunrise, every breath taken on this planet is a gift under this covenant.

Carry this verse with you this week. The next time you see a rainbow, say it. The next time it rains, remember the bow that hangs above the storm. By next week, the verse should be yours.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

The week centered on the Noahic Covenant. You read Genesis 8:20-9:29, Noah's first sacrifice after the flood, God's resolve never to curse the ground again, the institution of the rainbow as covenant sign. You read Genesis 10-11, the Table of Nations and the tower of Babel, humanity's pride scattered into the diverse peoples that the gospel would one day gather. You worshiped through Psalm 36 (God's steadfast love), Psalm 33:10-22 (God's sovereignty over nations), and Psalm 9 (the justice of God who hears the cry of the oppressed). And yesterday you completed the Unit 2 review, with Genesis 6:8 as the anchor, Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.

The week's theme is the foundation of common grace. Every harvest, every birth in every culture, every flicker of beauty in a fallen world, all of it operates under the Noahic Covenant. God preserves the world he made, so that redemption can unfold within it.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where in your life have you been taking common grace for granted? The Noahic Covenant is the foundation of every meal you eat, every season you enjoy, every breath you draw. These are gifts, not entitlements. Name one specific gift of common grace today, and receive it as such.

How does the Noahic Covenant point you to Christ? God's commitment to preserve the world after the flood was not the end of the story, it was the structural promise that held creation together so that the deeper covenant in Christ could come. The rainbow promises that God's judgment is not final; the cross proves it. Where do you most need the assurance today that judgment is not the final word for those in Christ?

How does the tower of Babel reshape how you see today's news? Humanity still gathers in pride. Humanity still tries to ascend to heaven on its own terms. Humanity still gets scattered. Where in your own life or your culture do you see Babel patterns? Where do you see Pentecost answers?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the rainbow, the seasons, and every harvest, and name one you enjoyed this week.

Ask him to open your eyes to common grace in the days ahead.

Rest in the deeper grace that has reached you in his Son.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 3 · DAYS 29-63

The Abrahamic Covenant

Genesis 12-50

God chooses one man to bless all nations. Election, promise, and faith.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

Psalm 105 retells the covenant with Abraham. Psalms 121, 124, 125, and 37 teach trust. Psalms 47 and 66 look to the nations.

UNIT 3

In this unit

WEEK 5

29	Genesis 12:1-13:18	*Reading*
30	Genesis 14:1-24	*Reading*
31	Genesis 15:1-21	*Reading*
32	Genesis 15:1-21; Jeremiah 31:31-34; Hebrews 8:6-13	*Doctrine*
33	Psalm 105:1-22	*Psalm*
34	Genesis 16:1-17:27	*Reading*
35	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 6

36	Genesis 18:1-19:38	*Reading*
37	Genesis 20:1-21:34	*Reading*
38	Genesis 22:1-24	*Reading*
39	Psalm 105:23-45	*Psalm*
40	Genesis 23:1-24:67	*Reading*
41	Genesis 25:1-26:35	*Reading*
42	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 7

43	Genesis 27:1-28:22	*Reading*
44	Genesis 29:1-30:43	*Reading*
45	Psalm 121	*Psalm*
46	Psalm 124; Psalm 125	*Psalm*
47	Genesis 31:1-32:32	*Reading*
48	Genesis 33:1-35:29	*Reading*
49	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 8

50	Genesis 36:1-37:36	*Reading*

51	Genesis 38:1-39:23	*Reading*
52	Psalm 37:1-22	*Psalm*
53	Psalm 37:23-40	*Psalm*
54	Genesis 40:1-41:57	*Reading*
55	Genesis 42:1-43:34	*Reading*
56	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 9

57	Genesis 44:1-45:28	*Reading*
58	Genesis 46:1-47:31	*Reading*
59	Genesis 48:1-50:26	*Reading*
60	Psalm 47	*Psalm*
61	Psalm 66:1-7	*Psalm*
62	Review and Reflection	*Review*
63	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 29 · WEEK 5

Genesis 12:1-13:18

The call of Abram; the covenant promise; election and blessing

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 12:1-13:18 slowly. This is one of the most important moments in the Bible, the call of Abram, which sets in motion the entire story of redemption. Notice what God promises, what Abram does, and how Abram's faith is mingled with very real failure.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Unit 2 ended at the scattering of Babel and narrowed to one man, Abram. Today the story shifts decisively. From here forward, the Bible focuses on one family through whom God will bring blessing to all the families of the earth. This is the great narrowing that becomes the great expanding. Abram is called out of Ur, away from his land and kindred, to a place he does not know. The promise he receives is unconditional: God will make him a great nation, bless him, and bless all nations through him. Everything in the rest of the Bible, Israel, Christ, the church, flows from this call.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God's call comes with three commands ("go") and seven promises, land, nation, blessing, great name, blessing to others, cursing of enemies, blessing of all families.
2. Abram is 75 years old and childless when he is called. The promise of a great nation requires faith from the start.
3. Verse 4: "So Abram went, as the LORD had told him." Obedience is immediate, without discussion.
4. Abram builds altars at Shechem and Bethel, claiming the land for the LORD by worship before he possesses it.

5. Famine drives Abram to Egypt, where he lies about Sarai being his sister. The chosen patriarch fails morally almost immediately.
6. Pharaoh, not Abram, ends up rebuking him. God protects the promise even when Abram does not.
7. Genesis 13: Lot and Abram separate. Abram gives Lot first choice of land, generosity flowing from trust in God's promise.
8. After Lot leaves, God reiterates and expands the promise: "all the land that you see I will give to you and to your offspring forever."

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 12 is where the story of redemption truly begins. The first eleven chapters of Genesis are sometimes called the prologue, creation, fall, flood, and Babel. From Genesis 12 onward, the Bible follows one family through whom God will reverse the curse of Babel and bring blessing to all the scattered nations.

Notice the structure of the call. God says three things to Abram: go from your country, go from your kindred, go from your father's house. Each command requires more sacrifice than the last. Country is general; kindred is closer; father's house is closest. God strips away every layer of identity Abram has built, geography, ethnicity, family, and asks him to find his identity in God alone. This is what every call of God involves at some level. Discipleship means letting God redefine who you are.

In exchange, God makes seven promises. He will make Abram a great nation, bless him, make his name great, make him a blessing, bless those who bless him, curse those who dishonor him, and bless all the families of the earth in him. Seven is the number of completeness. This is not a partial promise; it is a full, comprehensive commitment. And it is given to a 75-year-old man with a barren wife. From a human standpoint, every promise is impossible.

But Abram goes. Verse 4 is breathtaking in its brevity: "So Abram went, as the LORD had told him." No negotiation. No clarifying questions. He goes. This is what the New Testament will later call the obedience that comes from faith. Abram does not have full understanding. He has a promise from God, and that is enough.

Yet the chapter is honest about Abram's failure. As soon as famine strikes, he goes to Egypt, and there he lies about Sarai. He calls her his sister so that the Egyptians will not kill him to take her. The chosen patriarch protects himself by endangering his wife. God has just promised to bless him and curse those who curse him, and Abram does not trust the promise enough to tell the truth. The result is that Pharaoh rebukes Abram. The pagan king has more

integrity in this moment than the called patriarch. This is one of the Bible's repeated patterns: God's chosen people are real people with real failures, and the promise of God succeeds despite them, not because of them.

Then in chapter 13, after returning to Canaan, conflict arises between Abram's herdsmen and Lot's. Abram offers Lot first choice of land. Lot chooses the well-watered Jordan plain near Sodom. Abram is left with the hill country. But notice, after Lot leaves, God speaks again to Abram and expands the promise. "Lift up your eyes and look… for all the land that you see I will give to you and to your offspring forever." Abram lets go of his rights and God gives him more than he could have grasped for himself. This will be a pattern throughout the patriarchal narratives. Those who trust God do not need to defend their own interests; God defends them.

STEP 5

Connection

The scattering of Babel ended Unit 2 with humanity in pieces, alienated from God and from one another. Today's reading begins the answer. God will reunite the nations not by undoing the scattering but by working through one chosen family. The blessing promised to Abram in verse 3, "in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed", is the New Testament's gospel in seed form (Galatians 3:8). Every promise made to Abram is eventually fulfilled in Christ, who is the offspring through whom all nations are blessed.

STEP 6

Application

The call of Abram is the pattern for every Christian life. God calls. We go. We trust in promises we cannot fully see. We fail along the way, and God's promise stands anyway. Today, ask yourself: what is God asking you to leave behind? What identity, what comfort, what security has he asked you to release in order to find your life in him alone? And what promise has he given you that you are tempted not to trust? Faith is not the absence of fear or even of failure. It is going when God says go, building altars of worship along the way, and trusting that the same God who called you will keep his word.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what "going" might look like for you, and what makes it hard to trust him with it.

Confess any time you have schemed to protect yourself instead of trusting his promise.

Ask him to make you a person who builds altars of worship wherever he leads.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 5

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."

GENESIS 12:3

DAY 30 · WEEK 5

Genesis 14:1-24

Abram rescues Lot; Melchizedek, priest and king, bread and wine

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 14:1-24 slowly. This chapter contains a battle scene, a rescue, and one of the most theologically loaded encounters in the Old Testament: Abram's meeting with Melchizedek, a priest-king who blesses him with bread and wine. The chapter is short, but pay close attention, Hebrews 7 will treat this as a key Christological text.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday Abram and Lot separated. Lot chose the lush Jordan plain near Sodom, the region of cities we will hear about throughout the rest of Genesis. Today's chapter shows the danger of Lot's choice and the courage of Abram. Four kings from the east invade the area, defeat the kings of the cities of the plain, and carry off the spoils, including Lot. Abram, with only 318 trained men, pursues, defeats the invaders, and rescues Lot. On his return, he is met by two very different kings: the king of Sodom, who tries to negotiate with him, and Melchizedek, the mysterious king of Salem, who blesses him. The contrast between these two encounters is the heart of the chapter.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 13 calls Abram a "Hebrew" for the first time in Scripture, the term means "one who crosses over" and may relate to Abram's journey from Mesopotamia.
2. Abram has 318 trained men "born in his house." His household is large enough to constitute a small army.
3. He pursues the four kings as far as Dan in the north, over a hundred miles, and defeats them in a surprise night attack.

4. Melchizedek appears in only three verses (18-20), with no genealogy, no introduction, no follow-up, and never appears again in Genesis.
5. His name means “king of righteousness.” Salem (an early name for Jerusalem) means “peace.” He is king of righteousness and peace.
6. He brings out bread and wine, striking imagery that the New Testament will pick up.
7. Abram pays Melchizedek a tithe, a tenth of the spoils. This is the first tithe in the Bible, and it is paid to a priest greater than Abram.
8. The king of Sodom offers Abram the goods of victory. Abram refuses, swearing not to take “a thread or a sandal strap”, he will not be enriched by Sodom.
9. Abram’s refusal of Sodom’s wealth is paired with his receiving of Melchizedek’s blessing, accepting from God what he refuses from the world.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 14 is one of those chapters that seems simple on the surface but is theologically explosive once you see what it is doing. At the surface level, it is a story of military rescue. Underneath, it introduces one of the most important typological figures in all of Scripture: Melchizedek, the priest-king who prefigures Christ.

The military narrative is striking on its own. Abram, a peaceful nomadic patriarch, becomes a warrior to rescue his nephew. With 318 men, he pursues an alliance of four kings over a vast distance and defeats them. The text is not glorifying violence; it is showing that the man of faith is also a man of action when family is in danger. Faith does not produce passivity. It produces the kind of trust that enables courage.

But the heart of the chapter comes when Abram returns. Two kings meet him. The king of Sodom approaches with a transactional proposal: keep the goods, give me the people. The king of Salem approaches with bread, wine, and a blessing. The contrast is total. Sodom represents the world’s economy, favors traded, debts owed, transactions made. Melchizedek represents God’s economy, gifts given, blessings spoken, worship offered. Abram knows the difference. He refuses Sodom’s wealth and accepts Melchizedek’s blessing.

Who is Melchizedek? The text is remarkably restrained. He appears with no genealogy, no history, no future. He is king of Salem (later Jerusalem). He is priest of God Most High. He brings bread and wine. He blesses Abram. He receives a tithe. And then he vanishes from the narrative. The very absence of information is itself meaningful. He stands as a figure outside

the normal patterns of biblical genealogy, older than Abram (who pays him a tithe), greater than Abram (who receives his blessing), and unique in that he is both king and priest in a culture where those offices were rigidly separated.

The New Testament will pick this up with stunning force. Psalm 110 will declare of the coming Messiah: "You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek." And Hebrews 5-7 will spend three chapters showing that Jesus is the true Melchizedek, a priest-king greater than Aaron, greater than Abram, who offers bread and wine at the institution of the new covenant, who reigns over the true Salem, who blesses the children of Abram with all the spiritual blessings of God Most High. When Abram pays a tithe to Melchizedek, he is, in a sense, acknowledging the priority of Christ even before Christ comes. The whole Levitical priesthood that will later be established under Moses is foreshadowed and, in a sense, surpassed before it begins.

Abram's refusal of Sodom's wealth is the other side of the same coin. The man who has received from Melchizedek does not need to receive from Sodom. The believer who has received the blessing of God Most High does not need to be enriched by the world. The two transactions are mutually exclusive. You cannot worship at both altars. Abram chooses the higher one.

STEP 5

Connection

Abram's encounter with Melchizedek is one of the great Christological foreshadowings of the Old Testament. The priest-king of Salem, who brings out bread and wine and blesses the father of faith, points forward to the true priest-king Jesus, who instituted his new covenant with bread and wine and who blesses all the children of faith. Yesterday we saw the call of Abram, the beginning of God's promise to bless all nations. Today we see that the priest who blesses Abram already prefigures the priest through whom that blessing will ultimately come.

STEP 6

Application

Abram knew the difference between accepting blessing from God and being entangled with the world. Today, examine where you stand. From whom are you willing to receive? Are there "gifts" from the world, promotions, friendships, opportunities, recognition, that come with strings attached, that would compromise your loyalty to Christ? Abram knew that if he took Sodom's wealth, he could later be claimed by Sodom. The same is true today. Some offers must be refused, not because the things offered are inherently evil, but because their source would entangle you. Conversely, learn to receive from God. The Christian life is not earned; it is received. Receive your forgiveness. Receive your identity. Receive your daily

provisions. Receive the bread and the wine at the Lord's Supper, they come to you from your priest-king. And tithe, give back to God a portion of what he has given, as Abram did, recognizing the priority of the one who blesses you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Christ for being the priest and king who blesses you.

Ask God to help you refuse the gifts of Sodom and receive from him alone.

Tell him how you want to give back generously to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 5

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."

GENESIS 12:3

DAY 31 · WEEK 5

Genesis 15:1-21

The covenant cut; God alone passes through, pure grace

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 15:1-21 slowly. This is one of the most important chapters in the Old Testament. The Abrahamic Covenant is formally cut here, and the way God cuts it is shocking. Pay especially close attention to verse 6, which the New Testament will quote repeatedly as the foundation of justification by faith.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Abram has been called, has separated from Lot, has rescued Lot, and has refused Sodom's wealth. Now God comes to him again with reassurance. But Abram has been thinking. He is wealthy but childless. The promise of a great nation seems further away with each passing year. So in today's chapter, Abram does what he has not done before, he questions God. And God responds not with rebuke but with one of the most extraordinary covenant ceremonies in all of Scripture. This chapter contains the formal cutting of the Abrahamic Covenant, the seedbed of the gospel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God's opening words are striking: "Fear not, Abram, I am your shield; your reward shall be very great." God himself is Abram's shield and his reward.
2. Abram questions God for the first time: "O Lord GOD, what will you give me, for I continue childless?" Faith is allowed to ask honest questions.
3. God takes Abram outside, points him to the stars, and tells him his offspring will be that many. The promise is sealed under the night sky.
4. Verse 6 is the theological climax: "And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness." Justification by faith is born here.

5. When Abram asks how he will possess the land, God responds with a covenant ceremony, animals cut in two, pieces arranged in two rows.
6. Abram falls into a deep sleep and great darkness, the same word used of Adam's sleep in Genesis 2. Covenants involve a kind of death.
7. God reveals the future: 400 years of slavery in a foreign land, followed by exodus "with great possessions." History is foreseen and ordered.
8. Then "a smoking fire pot and a flaming torch passed between these pieces." God alone walks the path of the covenant, Abram does not.
9. The covenant is one-sided. God binds himself to fulfill the promise, regardless of Abram's faithfulness.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 15 is the chapter where the Abrahamic Covenant is formally cut, and the way God does it is one of the most remarkable scenes in the Bible. Once you understand what is happening, the gospel itself comes into focus.

The chapter begins with God reassuring Abram: "I am your shield; your reward shall be very great." This is enormous. God is not just giving Abram things; he is giving Abram himself. The shield is God. The reward is God. Every other promise, land, descendants, blessing, is secondary to this central reality. The greatest gift God gives his people is not what he gives them; it is himself.

But Abram is troubled. Time is passing and the promised son has not come. So Abram does something significant: he asks God a hard question. "What will you give me, for I continue childless?" This is faith being honest. Faith is not pretending that the promises feel fulfilled when they do not. Faith is bringing the unfulfilled promise back to the God who made it. Abram is not faithless here; he is faith-full in the most mature way. He takes God's promise seriously enough to ask about it.

God's response is to take Abram outside. Imagine the moment. The patriarch and the LORD, standing under the stars of the ancient Near East, a sky with no light pollution, blazing with millions of stars. "Look toward heaven, and number the stars, if you are able to number them. So shall your offspring be." It is a visual gospel. The promise is as vast as the cosmos.

And then comes verse 6, the single most important verse in the Old Testament for understanding the New Testament's doctrine of salvation. "And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness." Notice three things. First, Abram believed. Faith, not works, is what God responds to. Second, God counted his faith as righteousness. The verb is

the language of bookkeeping. God moves something into Abram's account. Third, Abram did nothing to earn this. He simply believed the promise and was reckoned righteous. Romans 4 and Galatians 3 will use this verse as the foundational proof that justification has always been by faith, never by works of the law.

But the chapter is not done. Abram still wants assurance about the land. "How am I to know that I shall possess it?" God responds by establishing the covenant in the way covenants were sealed in the ancient Near East. Two parties seeking covenant would cut animals in half, arrange the pieces in two rows, and walk together between them, a vivid symbol meaning, "Let me become like these animals if I break this covenant." It was a self-curse oath.

Abram prepares the animals as God instructs. He waits. A deep sleep falls on him. God speaks the future: 400 years of slavery in Egypt, then deliverance, then return to the land. History is being scripted from this moment forward.

And then comes the most stunning detail in the chapter. As the sun sets, "a smoking fire pot and a flaming torch passed between these pieces." The fire and the smoke represent God's presence, the same imagery that will later mark Mount Sinai and the Tabernacle. And God alone walks between the pieces. Abram, the human partner, sleeps. Only God passes through.

The meaning is overwhelming. In every other covenant ceremony of this kind, both parties walked through. Both parties bound themselves. Both said, "Let me become like these animals if I break my word." But here, only God walks. God binds himself unconditionally. Whatever happens to Abram or to Abram's descendants, the covenant rests on God alone. He alone is responsible for keeping it. And if anyone is to be torn like these animals to maintain the covenant, it will be God himself.

That is exactly what will happen. Centuries later, on a hill outside Jerusalem, God in human flesh will be torn, bearing the curse of the covenant his people have broken, so that the promise to bless all nations can stand. Abram saw it in shadow. We have seen it in light.

STEP 5

Connection

The first promise of redemption was given in Genesis 3:15, the offspring of the woman would crush the serpent. The line of promise has been preserved through Seth, Noah, Shem, and now Abram. Today the promise becomes covenant, formal, ceremonial, sealed in blood. Verse 6, "he believed the LORD, and it was counted to him as righteousness", is the heart of the gospel that Paul will preach in Romans 4 and Galatians 3. Abram is justified by faith, not by works. And the one-sided nature of the covenant points forward to Christ, who alone passes through the pieces, bearing the curse so that the blessing might come to all nations.

STEP 6

Application

Today, sit with verse 6 until it lands. You are justified by faith. Not by your performance. Not by your moral track record. Not by your religious effort. By faith, by believing the God who has promised, who has acted, who has sent his Son. Abram believed and was reckoned righteous. The same is true for you. If you have believed in Christ, his righteousness is counted to you, just as Abram's faith was counted to him. This is not a metaphor. It is the legal verdict of God over your life.

And sit with the one-sided covenant. God alone walked between the pieces because the covenant depends on him, not on you. If your faith feels weak, the covenant is still secure. If you fail, the covenant still stands. The God who bound himself to Abram has bound himself to you in Christ. Your security is not in the steadiness of your walking but in the faithfulness of his.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that your standing with him rests on his faithfulness and not yours.
- Confess any striving to earn what he has already given.
- Praise Christ who was torn so that you could be blessed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 5

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."

GENESIS 12:3

DAY 32 · WEEK 5

Genesis 15:1-21; Jeremiah 31:31-34; Hebrews 8:6-13

Covenant Theology, A Framework

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 15:1-21 again, then Jeremiah 31:31-34 and Hebrews 8:6-13. These three passages span the Bible's covenantal arc: the Abrahamic covenant, the promise of the new covenant, and the New Testament's announcement that the new covenant has come in Christ. Read them with the question in mind: what is a covenant, and why is it the structure of God's relationship with his people?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday you read the formal cutting of the Abrahamic Covenant, God alone walking between the pieces, binding himself to keep what he had promised. Today we pause to think more carefully about what covenants are and how they shape the entire Bible. Covenant is not a technical theological term invented by scholars. It is the Bible's own primary category for describing how God relates to his people. From Noah to Abraham to Moses to David to the new covenant in Christ, God always relates to his people through covenant. Understanding this category is essential for reading the Bible well.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Genesis 15 shows the basic pattern of a covenant: a sovereign initiates, makes promises, and seals them with an oath ceremony.
2. The Hebrew word berith ("covenant") first appears with Noah (Genesis 6:18), then runs through Abraham, Moses, David, and the prophets.
3. Jeremiah 31:31-34 promises a "new covenant" that will be different from the one God made when he brought Israel out of Egypt.

4. The new covenant features: law written on hearts, all knowing the LORD, sins forgiven and remembered no more.
5. Hebrews 8 explicitly identifies Christ as the mediator of this new covenant.
6. Christ's institution of the Lord's Supper uses the language of Jeremiah 31: "this is the new covenant in my blood" (Luke 22:20).
7. Every major covenant has a sign: rainbow (Noahic), circumcision (Abrahamic), Sabbath (Mosaic), throne (Davidic), the Lord's Supper (New).
8. The covenants build on one another, each new covenant fulfills what the previous covenants promised.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

A covenant, in the biblical sense, is a sworn relationship of personal commitment between God and his people. It is more than a contract, which is a transaction between equals for limited purposes. A covenant is a personal bond, sealed with promises and signs, that creates a relationship of mutual belonging. God says, in essence: I will be your God, and you will be my people.

The Bible's story is structured around a series of covenants. Each one builds on the others, fulfilling earlier promises while opening new dimensions. Understanding this structure is essential for reading Scripture well.

The first covenant in Scripture is the covenant with Noah (Genesis 9). It is universal, made with all humanity and all creation, and its purpose is preservation. God commits to maintain the natural order so that the larger story of redemption can unfold. The sign is the rainbow. This covenant is still in effect today.

The second is the covenant with Abraham (Genesis 12, 15, 17). It narrows from all humanity to one family, but with a promise that will eventually re-expand to bless all the families of the earth. Three things are promised: land, offspring, and universal blessing. The sign is circumcision. As you have just seen in Genesis 15, this covenant is unconditional, God alone walks between the pieces.

The third is the covenant with Moses at Sinai (Exodus 19-24). This is a covenant with the nation of Israel, organizing them as God's people under his law. Unlike the Abrahamic Covenant, this one has conditions, blessings for obedience, curses for disobedience. The sign is the Sabbath. The Mosaic Covenant does not replace the Abrahamic; it serves it, providing the structure by which Abraham's offspring would live as God's holy people in the land of promise.

The fourth is the covenant with David (2 Samuel 7). God promises David an everlasting throne. From his line will come a king whose kingdom will never end. The sign is the Davidic dynasty itself. This narrows further still, from a nation to a family within that nation, from a family to a king who will rule forever.

The fifth and final is the new covenant, promised in Jeremiah 31 and ratified in Christ. This is not merely another covenant; it is the fulfillment of all the others. Jeremiah describes it: God's law written on hearts (rather than tablets of stone), every member knowing the LORD personally (rather than learning from others), and sins forgiven definitively. The new covenant accomplishes what the Mosaic Covenant could not, it makes the relationship between God and his people internal, personal, and permanent.

Christians have debated for centuries how exactly the covenants relate to one another. Some traditions emphasize discontinuity, the new covenant is largely replacing the old. Other traditions emphasize continuity, the new covenant fulfills and extends the old. The framework this plan follows, sometimes called progressive covenantalism, sees the covenants as a unified, unfolding story. Each builds on the previous. Each is fulfilled in Christ. The Old Testament is not a different religion from the New Testament; it is the same story moving toward the same goal.

Several things follow from this. First, God always relates to his people through covenant. He does not deal with humanity merely as Creator or Lawgiver or Judge, but as covenant Lord, one who has bound himself to a people. Second, covenant is the structure of grace. Every covenant is initiated by God, not earned by humans. Even the conditional Mosaic Covenant comes only after God has already redeemed Israel from Egypt. Grace comes first; obligation responds. Third, the covenants are interconnected. The Abrahamic promise that all nations would be blessed finds its fulfillment in the new covenant, where Gentiles are grafted in. The Davidic promise of an everlasting king finds its fulfillment in Christ, whose throne is eternal. Fourth, Christ is the center. Every covenant points toward him. He is the offspring of Abraham (Galatians 3:16), the prophet greater than Moses (Hebrews 3:1-6), the Son of David, and the mediator of the new covenant.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three passages you read together tell the covenantal story of the Bible in three frames. Genesis 15 shows the unconditional commitment of God to Abram. Jeremiah 31 promises a new covenant that will accomplish what the Mosaic Covenant could not. Hebrews 8 declares that Christ is the mediator of this new covenant.

Look at Jeremiah 31:31 carefully. “Behold, the days are coming, declares the LORD, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah, not like the covenant that I made with their fathers on the day when I took them by the hand to bring them out of the land of Egypt, my covenant that they broke.” The Mosaic Covenant was broken. Despite all of God’s faithfulness, Israel could not be faithful in return. The law written on tablets of stone did not transform stone hearts. A new covenant was needed, one that would do something the old could not do.

And then Jeremiah lists the features of this new covenant. Three things stand out. First, the law will be written on hearts. The same God who etched the Ten Commandments on tablets at Sinai will now etch his law on the hearts of his people. Internal, not external. Second, all will know the LORD, from the least to the greatest. No more need for one Israelite to teach another to know the LORD; the relationship will be personal and universal. Third, sins will be forgiven and remembered no more. The sacrificial system of the Mosaic Covenant had to be repeated endlessly because the sins kept piling up. The new covenant deals with sin definitively.

Hebrews 8 then identifies the mediator of this new covenant: Christ. By his death, the new covenant has been ratified. By his Spirit, the law is being written on his people’s hearts. By his blood, sins are forgiven and remembered no more. The promise of Jeremiah 31 has been fulfilled. The covenant cut with Abram, sealed with God alone walking through the pieces, finds its ultimate fulfillment when Christ is torn on the cross, the divine party of the covenant bearing the curse so that the blessing of Abraham could come to all nations.

This is what it means to read the Bible covenantally. You do not see disconnected stories or random commandments. You see one God, one people, and one covenant promise unfolding in stages, each stage building on the last, all of them finding their yes in Christ (2 Corinthians 1:20).

STEP 5

Connection

Today’s doctrinal pause names what has been happening throughout your reading. God has been relating to his people through covenants from the beginning. Noah, Abraham, and the others you have read about are all participants in this single unfolding story. When you read the rest of the Old Testament, you will see Moses, David, and the prophets, each adding new dimensions to the covenantal story. And when you reach the New Testament, you will see Christ as the climax: the offspring of Abraham, the prophet like Moses, the Son of David, the mediator of the new covenant. The whole Bible is one story, and covenant is its spine.

STEP 6

Application

If you are a Christian, you are a covenant person. You are not relating to God merely as a generic worshiper or a religious seeker. You are bound to him by the new covenant in Christ's blood. Three implications follow.

First, your relationship with God is secure. Like Abram's covenant, the new covenant rests on God's commitment, not yours. The Father has bound himself to you in Christ. The Spirit has been given as the seal. You cannot break a covenant whose maintenance depends on God. Your assurance is grounded here.

Second, your relationship with God is communal. Covenants always create peoples, not just individuals. You are part of the church, the people of the new covenant. The Lord's Supper you share with other believers is the sign of this covenant. Do not try to live the Christian life alone. The covenant binds you to one another, not just to God.

Third, your relationship with God is transformational. The new covenant promised hearts changed, sins forgiven, and an intimate knowledge of the LORD. These are not future promises; they are present realities for everyone in Christ. The Spirit is writing God's law on your heart even now. Your sins are forgiven and remembered no more. You know the LORD, however dimly, because he has revealed himself to you. Live in light of this. You are not who you were. You are a new-covenant person, in Christ, by grace.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he binds himself to his people by promise, and ask him to make that real to you.

Thank Jesus as the mediator of the new covenant.

Ask him to help you live out of that security, together with his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 5

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."

GENESIS 12:3

DAY 33 · WEEK 5

Psalm 105:1-22

God's faithfulness to Abraham's covenant

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 105:1-22 slowly, twice. This is one of the Psalter's great historical psalms. It walks through the story of God's faithfulness to Abraham and his descendants. Read it as the appropriate response to the Abrahamic covenant story you have been encountering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 105 is one of the longest historical psalms in the Bible. It rehearses God's saving acts from Abraham to the conquest of Canaan. Today's reading covers the first 22 verses, from the covenant with Abraham through the early years of Joseph in Egypt. The psalm is essentially a hymn-form summary of Genesis 12-41 and a preparation for the Exodus to come. It teaches the people of God how to remember and how to give thanks.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with calls to give thanks, sing, and tell, worship as proclamation.
2. Verse 8 is the theological hinge: "He remembers his covenant forever, the word that he commanded, for a thousand generations."
3. Verses 9-10 specifically name the covenants with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, the patriarchal line.
4. Verse 11 quotes God's promise: "To you I will give the land of Canaan as your portion for an inheritance."
5. The patriarchs are called "few in number, of little account, and sojourners in it." Their smallness is part of the wonder.

6. Verses 14-15: “He allowed no one to oppress them; he rebuked kings on their account, saying, ‘Touch not my anointed ones, do my prophets no harm.’” God protected them.

7. Then the psalm pivots to Joseph: “He sent a man ahead of them, Joseph, who was sold as a slave.” God’s sovereignty in suffering.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 105:1-22 is a worship-form summary of everything you have been reading in Genesis. It begins with the call to remember, to give thanks, to sing, to tell. And then it remembers, by rehearsing the story of God’s covenant faithfulness to Abraham and his offspring.

Verse 8 is the central claim. “He remembers his covenant forever, the word that he commanded, for a thousand generations.” This is the antidote to the despair that often accompanies covenant life. The patriarchs lived through famine, infertility, betrayal, slavery. They lived in a land that was not yet theirs. They saw children but not grandchildren of the promise. And yet, through all of it, God remembered. The Hebrew word for remember in Scripture is not passive recollection. It is active loyalty. When God “remembers” his covenant, he is acting in faithfulness to it. The psalm announces that this remembering is not just for one generation. It is for a thousand. Forever.

Verses 9-11 quote the Abrahamic promise directly. The covenant with Abraham was confirmed to Isaac and renewed with Jacob. It is a single, unfolding promise, the same God to the same family with the same word about the same land. And verse 11 puts in God’s own mouth: “To you I will give the land of Canaan as your portion for an inheritance.” This is what Abram believed in Genesis 15, and what God reckoned to him as righteousness.

Then the psalm becomes startlingly honest about the smallness of the patriarchs. “When they were few in number, of little account, and sojourners in it, wandering from nation to nation, from one kingdom to another people.” This is the truth about Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. They were not powerful. They were not numerous. They were nomads, vulnerable to every famine and every local king. And yet, the psalm says, “he allowed no one to oppress them; he rebuked kings on their account.” Pharaoh in Egypt, Abimelech in Gerar, God protected the patriarchs even from the most powerful men of their day. He still does this with his people. We are few. We are weak. We are sojourners. And he protects us.

The psalm then turns to Joseph. “He sent a man ahead of them, Joseph, who was sold as a slave.” This is the heart of the Joseph story before Joseph even reaches Pharaoh’s house. God sent Joseph. Joseph was sold by his brothers, betrayed, enslaved, imprisoned, but God sent him. The same God who promised Abram a great nation arranged for Joseph to be in Egypt so that the family could later be preserved through famine. What looked from the ground

like tragedy and injustice was, from heaven's perspective, sovereign provision. This is the doctrine of providence in narrative form. And we will see it played out in full when we read Joseph's story in the next two weeks of this plan.

STEP 5

Connection

The first chapters of Unit 3 have introduced the patriarchs, Abraham primarily, with Isaac and Jacob and Joseph yet to come in greater detail. Today's psalm teaches us how to receive these stories. They are not just family history. They are the record of God's covenant faithfulness, remembered for a thousand generations. As the unit unfolds, we will see the patriarchs at their best and at their worst. Psalm 105 reminds us that the story is ultimately about the God who remembered, not about the people who were remembered.

STEP 6

Application

Make remembering a habit. The Christian life is not primarily about discovering new truths but about remembering old ones, that you were lost, that you were redeemed, that you are loved, that you are kept. Today, recall one specific way God has been faithful to you in the past. Name it. Thank him for it. Tell someone about it. This is what the psalmist commands: give thanks, sing, tell the deeds of the LORD. Worship is, in large part, memory exercised.

And take comfort from the smallness of the patriarchs. They were few. You may feel few. They were of little account in the world's eyes. You may feel of little account. They were sojourners. So are you. And the same God who protected them protects you. He has not forgotten his covenant. He remembers, for a thousand generations.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for remembering his covenant, and for remembering you in Christ.

Tell him about a season that feels like famine or slavery, and ask him to preserve you through it.

Ask him to teach you to tell of his works.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 5

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."

GENESIS 12:3

DAY 34 · WEEK 5

Genesis 16:1-17:27

Hagar and Ishmael; circumcision as covenant sign

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 16:1-17:27 carefully. These two chapters belong together: Genesis 16 shows Abram and Sarai trying to fulfill God's promise their own way through Hagar, and Genesis 17 shows God responding with renewed promise and the institution of circumcision as the sign of the covenant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It has been more than ten years since the promise. Abram is 86. Sarai is 76 and still childless. Faith and waiting wear on a person. Today's reading shows what happens when waiting becomes too painful, and what God does when his people take matters into their own hands. Genesis 16 is the Hagar story. Genesis 17 is God's reset: a renewed covenant, new names for Abram and Sarai, and the sign of circumcision marking every male in the household as belonging to the covenant.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Sarai's proposal, that Abram conceive a child through Hagar, was a culturally accepted practice in the ancient Near East, but it was outside God's promise.
2. Hagar conceives, and immediately the relationship sours. Hagar despises Sarai; Sarai blames Abram; Abram passes the buck back to Sarai.
3. God meets Hagar in the wilderness, the first appearance of "the angel of the LORD" in Scripture. He sees her and names her son Ishmael ("God hears").
4. Hagar names God: "You are a God of seeing." She is the only person in the Bible to give God a name.
5. Thirteen years pass between chapter 16 and chapter 17, silence between them.

6. God appears as “God Almighty” (El Shaddai), a name that emphasizes power adequate to the impossible.
7. Abram’s name is changed to Abraham (“father of many”). Sarai becomes Sarah. Names matter; identity is being reshaped.
8. Circumcision is instituted as the sign of the covenant, applied to every male in the household, including servants and the not-yet-born Isaac.
9. God repeats and intensifies the promise: nations will come from Abraham; kings will descend from him; the land is given as an everlasting possession.
10. When God promises Isaac will be born to Sarah, Abraham laughs. God names the coming son Isaac, which means “he laughs.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 16 and 17 belong together as a pair. They show what faith and unbelief look like when waiting on God’s promise. Genesis 16 is unbelief masquerading as practical wisdom. Genesis 17 is faith renewed by God himself.

The Hagar episode is a study in what happens when believers try to help God fulfill his promises through ungodly means. Sarai’s proposal was culturally normal in the ancient Near East. A barren wife could have a child through her servant, and the child would legally be considered hers. From a human standpoint, it was a reasonable plan. From God’s standpoint, it was a substitute. God had promised a child through Sarai. The child Sarai wanted through Hagar was not the promised child.

The consequences come quickly. Hagar conceives and despises her mistress. Sarai blames Abram for the situation she created. Abram refuses to lead and passes the problem back to Sarai. The household fractures. Hagar flees into the wilderness. This is what happens when believers try to manufacture God’s promises through their own ingenuity. The results are bitterness, blame, and broken relationships. God’s promises cannot be helped along by human strategy. They can only be received in faith.

But notice what God does for Hagar. He meets her in the wilderness. The angel of the LORD, almost certainly a pre-incarnate appearance of Christ, speaks to her by name. He hears her affliction. He gives her a promise about her son. Hagar’s response is one of the most remarkable confessions in the Bible: “You are a God of seeing… Truly here I have seen him who looks after me.” Hagar is the only person in Scripture who gives God a name. And the God she names is the God who sees the rejected, the abandoned, the wronged. This is who God is. Even in the middle of human failure, he meets the casualties with personal kindness.

Thirteen years of silence pass between chapters 16 and 17. Long silences are common in the patriarchal narratives. Faith must learn to wait. And then God appears again to Abram, this time as "God Almighty", El Shaddai. The name emphasizes God's power to do what nothing and no one else can do. It is the right name for this moment, because what God is about to promise is impossible.

The covenant is renewed with significant changes. Abram becomes Abraham, "father of a multitude." Sarai becomes Sarah, "princess." Names are not arbitrary in Scripture; they carry identity. By renaming them, God is reshaping who they are. They will live, from this point forward, as the people whose new identities reflect the promised future.

The sign of the covenant is introduced: circumcision. Every male in Abraham's household, including the servants, is to be circumcised. Why this sign? Several reasons. It marks the body, a permanent, irreversible sign of belonging to the covenant. It marks the organ of procreation, the means by which the promised line will continue. And it costs something, a literal cutting of the flesh that reminds the bearer that covenant entails cost. Paul will later argue that this sign was meant to anticipate the deeper cutting of the heart that the new covenant brings (Romans 2:29).

The chapter ends with Abraham laughing. God promises that Sarah will bear a son within the year, and Abraham falls on his face laughing, a complex laughter that is part joy, part disbelief, part wonder. God responds by naming the coming child Isaac, which means "he laughs." The first laughter in the Bible is the laughter of doubt; the next will be Sarah's laughter when she overhears the same promise. But God transforms their doubt-laughter into the name of the promised son. The God of grace turns even the patriarchs' unbelief into a memorial of his faithfulness.

STEP 5

Connection

The Abrahamic Covenant was cut in Genesis 15 with God alone walking through the pieces. Here in Genesis 17, it is renewed and given a sign, circumcision. Every Israelite from this point forward will bear in his body the mark of belonging to Abraham's covenant. The sign points forward to the deeper reality of the new covenant, where the heart itself is circumcised by the Spirit (Romans 2:29; Colossians 2:11). The Hagar episode also looks forward, Paul will use Hagar and Sarah as a contrast between the old covenant (children of slavery) and the new (children of promise) in Galatians 4.

STEP 6

Application

Wait. This is the lesson of these two chapters. When God makes a promise, the temptation is always to help him keep it through our own ingenuity. We propose Hagars. We construct alternatives. We persuade ourselves that we are being practical. And we wreck things in the process. Today, ask yourself: is there a promise of God that you have been trying to manufacture through worldly means? A relationship you are trying to force? An outcome you are trying to engineer? A future you are trying to secure on your own? Bring it back to God. Wait. The same God who waited until Sarah was ninety to send Isaac knows how to fulfill his promises in his time.

And take comfort from Hagar. God sees the casualties of human failure. He sees the wronged, the rejected, the abandoned. If you are one of them today, know that the God of Abraham is also the God who sees you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have tried to help God keep his promises by your own schemes.
- Ask him to teach you to wait, and tell him what is hard about it.
- Thank him that he sees and hears those who are overlooked.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 5

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."

GENESIS 12:3

DAY 35 · WEEK 5

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. The week you have completed introduced the man at the center of the rest of the Bible, Abraham. Take time today to let the sweep of his calling settle. The promise made to him is the promise that reaches you.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."

GENESIS 12:3

REST

Meditation

Genesis 12:3 is the seed of the gospel in the Old Testament. Paul calls it the gospel preached to Abraham (Galatians 3:8). The promise made to one man is the promise that ultimately reaches every nation, every family, every reader.

Say the verse aloud, and notice what is and is not promised. It does not promise Abraham personal prosperity. It does not promise his descendants ease. It promises blessing, and blessing of a particular kind, blessing that flows outward. Abraham is blessed in order to be a blessing.

The same is true of you. If you are in Christ, you are a child of Abraham (Galatians 3:7). The blessing of Abraham, flowing through Christ, has reached you. And it has not reached you so that it stops with you. You have been blessed in order to be a blessing. Carry the verse this week with two questions: How has God blessed me through Abraham's offspring, Jesus? And to whom is he sending that blessing through me?

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week was the great narrowing. After Unit 2 ended with the scattering of Babel, God called one man, Abram, and through him began the redemption of all the nations he had just scattered. You read Abram's call in Genesis 12 and watched him obey, even with his failures. You met Melchizedek, the priest-king who prefigures Christ. You read the formal cutting of the Abrahamic Covenant in Genesis 15, with God alone walking between the pieces. You sat with the doctrinal pause on Covenant Theology, the structure that runs through the entire Bible. You worshiped with Psalm 105:1-22, which sings the patriarchal promise. And you read the Hagar story and the renewal of the covenant in Genesis 17.

The week's center of gravity is the covenant. God binds himself to one family so that, through that family, all families of the earth will be blessed.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where in your life have you been trying to fulfill God's promises through your own scheming? Sarai's proposal of Hagar was the practical, culturally accepted alternative to waiting. It produced bitterness, blame, and broken relationships. Where are you tempted to engineer what God has already promised to provide? What would it look like to wait instead?

What does it mean that you, a Gentile reader, are included in the promise of Genesis 12:3? In Galatians 3, Paul says that those who are of faith are children of Abraham, that the blessing promised to all nations has come to you through Christ. Sit with this. You are part of the answer to Abraham's calling. How does that reshape your sense of identity, your sense of mission, your sense of belonging?

How did the doctrinal pause on Covenant Theology this week clarify your reading of the Bible? Covenant is the structure through which God relates to his people from Noah to Christ. What is one specific way this framework has begun to change how you understand the Bible as one unified story?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are a child of Abraham by faith, brought near by Christ.

Thank Christ for keeping the covenant that you could not.

Ask him to make you a blessing to someone this coming week.

DAY 36 · WEEK 6

Genesis 18:1-19:38

The visitors; Abraham intercedes; Sodom destroyed

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 18:1-19:38. These two chapters tell the linked stories of God's visit to Abraham and the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah. They belong together, the same God who promises blessing also brings judgment. Pay attention to Abraham's bold intercession, Lot's compromised life, and the contrasting endings of the two families.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Abraham has been circumcised. The covenant has been renewed. Now three visitors arrive at Abraham's tent in the heat of the day. One of them is the LORD himself. The visit will accomplish two things: confirm the imminent birth of Isaac, and reveal the coming judgment on Sodom. Today's reading shows the close relationship between promise and judgment in the life of God's people. The same God who blesses also judges. And in the middle of it all, Lot, Abraham's compromised nephew, is rescued from the burning cities, barely.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Abraham shows extravagant hospitality to the three visitors, washing their feet, preparing a feast, standing while they eat.
2. The LORD promises that Sarah will have a son "about this time next year." Sarah laughs from inside the tent.
3. Sarah's laughter is rebuked but not punished. God hears her, even when she denies laughing.
4. Verses 17-19 are striking: God deliberates whether to hide his plan from Abraham, then decides to reveal it.

5. Abraham's intercession for Sodom (verses 22-33) moves in stages: 50, 45, 40, 30, 20, 10. Each request is bolder, but each is granted.
6. God's openness to Abraham's prayer is remarkable. The patriarch genuinely shapes the conversation.
7. Genesis 19 opens with Lot sitting in the gate of Sodom, a place of civic leadership. He has become a Sodomite in residence.
8. The men of Sodom demand to abuse the visitors. Lot offers his daughters instead, a horrifying response that shows how compromised he has become.
9. The angels strike the men with blindness and pull Lot back into the house. Even in his failure, God's grace pursues him.
10. Lot's wife looks back and becomes a pillar of salt. Lot's daughters get him drunk and conceive, Moab and Ammon, future enemies of Israel.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 18 and 19 are one of the most stark contrasts in the Old Testament. The two chapters happen at the same time but in different places. In one, the LORD eats a meal with Abraham, promises a son, and listens to bold intercession. In the other, fire falls from heaven and ancient cities are destroyed. The same God acts in both. The difference is not in God; it is in the relationship those two households have with him.

The visit to Abraham is extraordinary. Three strangers arrive at his tent, and Abraham extravagantly serves them. Only as the meal unfolds does it become clear that one of them is the LORD himself, perhaps a pre-incarnate appearance of Christ, accompanied by two angels. The same LORD who promised Abraham a son is now sitting under his tree, eating his food, and confirming the timeline.

But the visit is also for another purpose. The LORD says, "Shall I hide from Abraham what I am about to do?" And he reveals the coming judgment on Sodom. This is what it means to be a friend of God, and Abraham is called the friend of God multiple times in Scripture. Friends are told things. Servants are given orders. Friends are admitted into the deliberations of their friend's heart. Abraham is being told the future not so he can run for cover but so he can intercede.

And intercede he does. The negotiation between Abraham and God is one of the most remarkable passages in the Bible. Abraham works his way down, what if there are 50 righteous? 45? 40? 30? 20? 10? Each time, God agrees. Each time, Abraham draws nearer. This

is not Abraham manipulating God. This is God inviting Abraham into a conversation about justice. The patriarch is being trained to think and feel as God does, caring about the righteous, longing for mercy, willing to plead for cities he does not even live in.

Then the scene shifts. Genesis 19 opens with Lot. He has come a long way from when he and Abram first separated. Lot is now sitting in the gate of Sodom, the place where civic leaders gather. He has become a man of standing in a wicked city. His compromise is total. When the angels arrive, the men of Sodom surround the house demanding to abuse them. Lot's response is horrifying: he offers his own daughters to be raped instead. This is what years of living in Sodom have done to him. His moral center has so eroded that he is willing to sacrifice his daughters to maintain the cultural code of hospitality.

The angels rescue Lot anyway. They strike the attackers with blindness, drag Lot back into the house, and the next morning practically force him out of the city. "The LORD being merciful to him." Lot is saved not because of his faithfulness but because of God's mercy and Abraham's prayer. This is one of the clearest pictures in the Old Testament of grace operating despite human failure.

The endings of the two stories are painfully different. Abraham's tent ends in joy, laughter, food, promise, intercession. Lot's home ends in flame, salt, drunkenness, and incest. The two daughters, having lost everything, get their father drunk and conceive children. The two children, Moab and Ammon, will become nations that war against Israel for centuries. Lot's compromise produces a legacy of enemies. Abraham's faithfulness produces a legacy of promise.

The lesson is clear and sobering. Where you choose to live matters. The company you keep matters. The cities of Sodom looked attractive to Lot when he first chose them; they cost him everything in the end. Abraham, who chose the harder hill country, was the one with whom the LORD shared his meals and his plans.

STEP 5

Connection

The Abrahamic Covenant included the promise that God would "curse those who dishonor" Abraham. Today we see the inverse: God reveals his plans to Abraham as his friend, and rescues Abraham's compromised nephew because of him. The intercession Abraham offers prefigures Christ's intercession for his people, bold, persistent, asking for mercy on the basis of God's character. And the destruction of Sodom prefigures the final judgment, which Jesus himself will compare to the days of Lot (Luke 17:28-32).

STEP 6

Application

Two warnings and one comfort.

First warning: be careful where you settle. Lot did not become wicked overnight. He drifted, decision by decision, into a city that ultimately consumed him. The places you choose to live, the people you choose to befriend, the environments you choose to immerse yourself in, these shape you over time. Do not assume you will be unaffected.

Second warning: take Christ's words seriously. Jesus said, "Remember Lot's wife" (Luke 17:32). She turned back. She had been told not to. And her brief, longing look backward froze her in place forever. Do not look back at what God is rescuing you out of. Move forward.

The comfort: Abraham interceded for Sodom, and Lot was rescued. Christ intercedes for his people, and we are rescued. If you know someone today who is compromised, who is sitting in the gate of Sodom, who is drifting away from God, pray for them. Stand before God on their behalf. Abraham's intercession was not wasted, and yours will not be either.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to make you a friend he can trust with his purposes.

Pray for someone you love who is drifting toward compromise, in the way Abraham pleaded for Lot.

Confess any drift of your own, and ask him to turn you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 6

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

DAY 37 · WEEK 6

Genesis 20:1-21:34

Abimelech; Isaac born, the promised son arrives

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 20:1-21:34. These chapters cover Abraham's second deception (he again calls Sarah his sister) and the long-awaited birth of Isaac. Notice how God protects Abraham even when Abraham fails, and how the promise finally arrives after twenty-five years of waiting.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It has been twenty-five years since Abraham was first called. He has aged. Sarah has aged. The promise of a son has lived in his household longer than many marriages last. Today's reading is the climax of the long wait. But it begins with another shameful episode, Abraham again lying about Sarah being his sister, this time to Abimelech of Gerar. The text candidly shows that the chosen patriarch has not learned from his earlier mistake. And yet, in the middle of his failure, the promise finally arrives. Isaac is born.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Abraham repeats the sin of Genesis 12, telling Abimelech that Sarah is his sister.
2. Abimelech, the pagan king, has more integrity than Abraham. God protects Sarah by appearing to Abimelech in a dream.
3. Verse 7 calls Abraham a "prophet", the first occurrence of the word in Scripture, applied to the man who has just lied.
4. Abraham prays for Abimelech's household and they are healed. God uses imperfect prophets.
5. Isaac is born in 21:2: "The LORD did to Sarah as he had promised." Twenty-five years of waiting is summed up in one verse.

6. Isaac's name means "he laughs." Sarah says, "God has made laughter for me; everyone who hears will laugh over me."
7. Tensions flare again between Sarah and Hagar. Sarah demands Hagar and Ishmael be cast out. God tells Abraham to do as Sarah says.
8. God meets Hagar in the wilderness a second time. He hears the boy's voice and provides water.
9. The chapter ends with Abraham planting a tamarisk tree at Beersheba and calling on the name of the LORD, "the Everlasting God."

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 20 and 21 belong together as a pair. The first chapter shows Abraham's continuing weakness; the second shows God's unfailing promise. The point is the same one the Bible has been making since Noah: God's covenant succeeds despite his people, not because of them.

Genesis 20 is one of those passages that makes Christians uncomfortable. Abraham, the great patriarch, lies again. He tells Abimelech of Gerar that Sarah is his sister, and Abimelech, believing him, takes her into his household. This is the second time Abraham has done this. He has not learned. The man whom we have come to admire for his faith is also a man who repeatedly tries to protect himself by endangering his wife.

But notice what God does. God comes to Abimelech in a dream and warns him. Abimelech, a pagan king, listens to God and protects Sarah. The text is making a point: God can protect the covenant even from the covenant-bearer's failures. The promise does not depend on Abraham's performance. It depends on God's faithfulness.

And then comes one of the most surprising verses in Genesis. God tells Abimelech, "He is a prophet, and he will pray for you, and you shall live." Abraham, who has just lied, is called a prophet. He is told to pray for the king he wronged. And God heals Abimelech's household. This is the strange and beautiful logic of grace. God uses imperfect people. He calls liars prophets. He turns failures into intercessors. If you have been waiting to be useful to God until you are no longer a sinner, you will wait forever. Abraham was useful to God while still sinning.

Genesis 21 then brings the long-awaited miracle. Verse 2: "Sarah conceived and bore Abraham a son in his old age at the time of which God had spoken to him." Twenty-five years compressed into a single sentence. The covenant has produced its first fruit. The promise has begun to be fulfilled in flesh and blood. Isaac is here.

His name, laughter, captures everything. Sarah laughed in Genesis 18 when she overheard the promise. She is laughing now in Genesis 21 because the promise has come true. "Everyone who hears will laugh over me." The God who keeps impossible promises is the God who produces joy in his people. The laughter of unbelief has been transformed into the laughter of fulfillment.

But the chapter also contains pain. Tensions with Hagar and Ishmael flare again. Sarah demands they be cast out. Abraham is grieved, Ishmael is his son too. But God tells Abraham to do as Sarah says, and God promises to take care of Hagar and Ishmael himself. He does. He meets Hagar in the wilderness a second time, hears the boy's cries, opens her eyes to see a well, and pledges to make Ishmael into a nation.

Paul will later use this episode allegorically in Galatians 4 to contrast the two covenants, Hagar representing slavery and law, Sarah representing freedom and promise. The point Paul draws out is already present in the narrative: the child of the slave woman cannot be the heir of the promise. The promise comes through the impossible son, miraculously given, freely received.

The chapter ends with Abraham planting a tamarisk tree at Beersheba and calling on the name of the LORD, El Olam, the Everlasting God. After twenty-five years of waiting, after laughter and tears, after lies and miracles, Abraham worships the God whose timeline is eternal and whose promises do not fail.

STEP 5

Connection

Twenty-five years ago in this plan's timeline, Abraham was called and given a promise. Today, the promise is fulfilled in Isaac. The faithfulness of God across that long wait is what the whole Bible is about. Isaac is the promised son, born by miracle to aged parents, and he points forward to the greater promised Son, born by miracle to a virgin, the true offspring of Abraham in whom all nations will be blessed. Sarah's laughter prefigures Mary's Magnificat. The God who made Sarah laugh is the God who makes his people sing.

STEP 6

Application

The promise comes, but it takes time. Today, take heart from twenty-five years. The God who fulfilled the promise to Abraham is the same God who has made promises to you. If you have been waiting for years for something, a healing, a reconciliation, a child, a calling, a deliverance, Abraham's story is your story too. God does not forget. He has not abandoned you. The timeline of fulfillment is not the timeline of impatience.

And take heart from the fact that Abraham, who lied repeatedly, was called a prophet and used by God to bring healing. Your failures do not disqualify you from being used by God. The covenant rests on him, not on you. Keep walking. Keep praying. Keep planting trees of worship in every place God brings you. The Everlasting God is faithful.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you are waiting for, and where waiting has tempted you to scheme.

Thank him that his promises come in his time.

Ask him to use you in the middle of your failures.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 6

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

DAY 38 · WEEK 6

Genesis 22:1-24

The binding of Isaac, substitution, faith, the mountain of the Lord

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 22:1-24 with great care. This is one of the most theologically loaded chapters in the entire Old Testament, the binding of Isaac. Hebrews 11, Romans 8, and the entire Gospel of John echo this passage. Read it slowly, as if you have never read it before.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaac is the promised son. He is the fulfillment of twenty-five years of waiting, the carrier of the covenant, the link between Abraham and the great nation that is to come. And today, God asks Abraham to kill him. This chapter is one of the most disturbing and one of the most glorious in the Bible. It tests Abraham's faith to its absolute limit. It reveals the depth of his trust in God. And it foreshadows, more clearly than almost any other Old Testament passage, the sacrifice that God himself will one day make.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 1 frames the entire chapter: "After these things God tested Abraham." What follows is a test, not a divine cruelty.
2. God's command is excruciatingly specific: "Take your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love." Three layers of identity, son, only son, beloved.
3. Abraham rises "early in the morning", immediate obedience, the same phrase used in Genesis 19:27 when he prayed for Sodom.
4. The three-day journey to Moriah gave Abraham time to second-guess. He did not turn back.

5. Verse 5 contains a remarkable statement: “We will worship and come again to you.” Abraham expected to return WITH Isaac.
6. Verse 8: “God will provide for himself the lamb.” This becomes the chapter’s central theological claim.
7. Isaac, old enough to carry the wood, does not resist. He is a willing participant in his own near-sacrifice.
8. The angel of the LORD calls from heaven at the climactic moment. The knife is stopped mid-air.
9. A ram is caught in the thicket. Abraham offers the ram “instead of his son”, substitutionary sacrifice in pure form.
10. Abraham names the place “The LORD will provide” (Yahweh-yireh).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 22 is one of the most theologically dense chapters in the Bible. It tests Abraham’s faith, demonstrates the principle of substitutionary sacrifice, and foreshadows the death of Christ with such specificity that it is hard to read any other way once you see it.

The chapter opens with a sentence that frames everything. “After these things God tested Abraham.” This is a test. God is not changing his mind about the covenant. He is not reverting to child sacrifice. He is testing the depth of Abraham’s faith. Abraham does not know it is a test. We, the readers, are told. This is important. Abraham acts in faith without knowing the outcome. We watch knowing how the story ends. Both perspectives matter.

God’s command lands with maximum weight. “Take your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love, and go to the land of Moriah, and offer him there as a burnt offering.” Three terms of endearment piled on top of each other. The very son who was promised. The son for whom Abraham waited twenty-five years. The son in whom the covenant rests. Offer him. The Hebrew is clear: kill him and burn him.

Abraham’s response is the stuff of faith’s hall of fame. He gets up early the next morning. He saddles the donkey. He gathers wood. He takes Isaac and two servants. He goes. There is no argument, no negotiation, no delay. Hebrews 11 tells us what was going on in his heart: “He considered that God was able even to raise him from the dead, from which, figuratively speaking, he did receive him back.” Abraham reasoned this way: God promised that through Isaac my offspring would be reckoned. If I kill Isaac, God must raise him from the dead, because his promise cannot fail. This is faith at its zenith, trusting God’s faithfulness even more than the apparent meaning of his command.

The three-day journey is excruciating. Abraham had time to second-guess. He did not. When they arrived, he told the servants, “Stay here with the donkey; I and the boy will go over there and worship and come again to you.” Notice: we will come again. Plural. Abraham expected to return with Isaac, one way or another. He did not know how, but he knew God.

The most haunting moment in the chapter is verse 7. Isaac, carrying the wood, asks his father: “Behold, the fire and the wood, but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?” Abraham’s answer is one of the most beautiful sentences in the Old Testament: “God will provide for himself the lamb.” It is both a comforting word to Isaac and a prophecy Abraham could not have fully understood. God will provide the lamb. Centuries later, John the Baptist will see Jesus walking toward him and say, “Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world.” God did provide. He provided himself.

The climactic moment comes with the knife raised. The angel of the LORD calls from heaven. Abraham’s hand is stayed. He sees a ram caught in a thicket. He sacrifices the ram “instead of his son.” This is substitutionary atonement in its purest visual form. The son is spared because the ram dies in his place. Abraham names the place “The LORD will provide”, Yahweh-yireh.

The chapter ends with a renewed and intensified promise. Because Abraham did not withhold his son, God will surely bless him, multiply his offspring as the stars and the sand, and through his offspring all the nations of the earth will be blessed. The blessing is now sealed by Abraham’s tested obedience.

But the deepest layer of this chapter only becomes visible from the New Testament side. Abraham was asked to do what he was, in the end, not asked to complete. God himself, however, did not spare his only beloved Son. Romans 8:32 echoes Genesis 22 directly: “He who did not spare his own Son but gave him up for us all, how will he not also with him graciously give us all things?” The same word, did not spare, appears in both. At Moriah, the son was spared. At Calvary, the Son was not. Because God provided for himself the Lamb.

STEP 5

Connection

The Abrahamic Covenant has been given, cut, signed, fulfilled in Isaac’s birth, and now tested at the mountain of the LORD. The mountain is Moriah, the same region where the Temple will later be built, where centuries of sacrifices will be offered, and (according to Jewish tradition) very near where Christ will be crucified. The chapter is a foreshadowing of the Gospel itself. The beloved son carrying wood up the hill of the LORD. The substitute provided by God. The son spared because another died in his place. The blessing of all nations flowing from one obedient man. Every detail points forward to Calvary.

STEP 6

Application

What is your Isaac? It is a question every believer must eventually face. What has God given you that you would struggle to give back to him? It might be a relationship. A career. A child. A reputation. A dream. The God who tests his people will, sooner or later, ask you to hold whatever you love with an open hand. He may not require you to give it up. He often does not. But he requires you to be willing.

This is hard. It feels like cruelty when you first encounter it. But it is mercy. God knows that whatever you cannot release will eventually rule you. The thing you grip most tightly is the thing most likely to become your god. He asks you to release Isaac so that Isaac can be received back, but as gift, not as idol.

Today, name your Isaac. Bring it before God. Hold it loosely. And remember: the God who tested Abraham is the same God who did not spare his own Son. He has already given his most. Trust him with yours.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he did not spare his own Son for you.

Ask him to show you what you are holding too tightly, and to help you open your hand.

Praise Christ as the Lamb God provided.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 6

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

DAY 39 · WEEK 6

Psalm 105:23-45

From Joseph to the Exodus, God's faithfulness through adversity

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 105:23-45 slowly, twice. This is the second half of the historical psalm we began on Day 29. Today's section covers Joseph in Egypt through the Exodus, God's faithfulness across centuries and through hardship. It is the perfect bridge from the patriarchal stories to the next phase of God's covenant work.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 105 began with Abraham and the patriarchs. Today's portion picks up at Joseph's descent into Egypt and traces God's faithfulness through the years of slavery, the plagues, the Exodus, and the wilderness wanderings, all the way to the gift of the land. The psalm is a sweeping summary of the next several units in this plan. It rehearses what God has done so that the people of God will know how to give thanks.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 23: "Then Israel came to Egypt; Jacob sojourned in the land of Ham." The patriarchal family becomes a nation in exile.
2. Verse 24: "And the LORD made his people very fruitful and made them stronger than their foes." Multiplication in exile.
3. Verse 25 is striking: "He turned their hearts to hate his people." Even Egyptian hostility is under God's sovereignty.
4. Moses and Aaron are sent, chosen instruments for the deliverance to come.
5. Verses 27-36 summarize the ten plagues in poetic form. Each is an attack on Egypt's gods.

6. Verse 37: “Then he brought out Israel with silver and gold, and there was none among his tribes who stumbled.” Provision and protection.
7. Verses 39-41: The pillar of cloud, the manna, the water from the rock, wilderness providence.
8. Verse 42 is the theological refrain: “For he remembered his holy promise, and Abraham, his servant.” Everything that happened was the fulfillment of the covenant.
9. The psalm ends with the gift of the land, “the lands of the nations”, and the call to praise the LORD.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 105:23-45 is the divine view of Israel’s long story. From the ground, the descent into Egypt looked like tragedy. The years of slavery looked like abandonment. The plagues and the Exodus looked like a contested struggle. From God’s perspective, every step was the fulfillment of his promise to Abraham. This is what historical psalms do. They take the grand sweep of redemptive history and show how every event served God’s covenantal purposes.

Verse 23 introduces Egypt by saying Jacob “sojourned in the land of Ham.” This is theologically loaded. Ham was Noah’s son, and the land of Ham represents the post-flood world outside the line of promise. Israel is now in that world, far from the land of promise, surrounded by foreign gods, growing in number among people who do not know the LORD.

But notice verse 24: “He made his people very fruitful and made them stronger than their foes.” This echoes Genesis 1:28, be fruitful and multiply. The dominion mandate is being fulfilled even in slavery. God’s people grow in number in the very land that will eventually try to crush them. This is one of the great patterns of biblical theology. God multiplies his people in the most hostile environments.

Verse 25 is one of the most theologically remarkable verses in the Psalter: “He turned their hearts to hate his people, to deal craftily with his servants.” Even Egyptian hostility was under God’s sovereign control. This does not mean God caused sin in the Egyptians’ hearts. It means he ordered history in such a way that their natural hostility served his redemptive purpose. The same Pharaoh who oppressed Israel becomes the means by which Israel is forged into a nation and then delivered with mighty signs. Romans 9 will appeal to this principle when Paul discusses God’s sovereignty over Pharaoh’s hardening.

The psalm then summarizes the plagues. What strikes the modern reader is how each plague is described as God’s action. He turned waters to blood. He sent flies. He gave them hail. He spoke and locusts came. The plagues are not natural disasters. They are direct interventions

of the covenant Lord against the gods of Egypt. Each plague targets a specific deity, Hapi the Nile god, Heqet the frog goddess, Ra the sun god, and so on. The plagues are theological warfare.

The Exodus itself is described as victory and provision. "Then he brought out Israel with silver and gold, and there was none among his tribes who stumbled." The people who entered Egypt as a small clan leave as a great nation, loaded with the wealth of their oppressors, none of them sick or weak. This is the God who keeps his promises.

And then verses 39-41 cover the wilderness. The cloud by day, the fire by night. Manna from heaven. Water from the rock. The providence of God in the desert. The psalmist is preparing us for the next two units of our reading, Exodus through Deuteronomy, and reminding us that this whole period was God's faithful provision.

Verse 42 is the hinge: "For he remembered his holy promise, and Abraham, his servant." Everything in the Exodus story flows from the Abrahamic Covenant. The plagues, the deliverance, the wilderness provision, the inheritance of the land, all of it is the fulfillment of what God promised Abraham four hundred years earlier. The covenants of God do not expire. They unfold.

The psalm closes with the gift of the land. God gave them the lands of the nations. They received the fruit of others' labor. Not because they deserved it, but because God had promised. And the only fitting response is praise. Hallelujah.

STEP 5

Connection

Today's psalm is a bridge. It looks back over what we have read, God's covenant with Abraham, his faithfulness through the patriarchs, his preservation in Egypt, and forward to what we will read next: the Exodus, the wilderness, and the entry into the land. Everything that happens in the next several units of this plan is the unfolding of the promise made to Abraham. The psalm helps us see the whole arc.

STEP 6

Application

Live in the awareness that every part of your story is part of God's larger story. The descent into difficult times may feel like loss, but God multiplied Israel in Egypt. The years of waiting may feel like abandonment, but God remembered his promise. The hostility you face may feel personal, but God has used the hostility of others to forge his people for generations. Whatever you are walking through today, ask the question Psalm 105 keeps asking: how is this serving God's larger purposes? You may not know in the moment. Israel did not know in the moment. But God remembered, and he is remembering still.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for being faithful across long years of waiting and trouble.

Tell him about a season that feels like Egypt, and ask him to make you fruitful there.

Ask him to bring you into all he has promised.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 6

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

DAY 40 · WEEK 6

Genesis 23:1-24:67

Sarah's death; Isaac and Rebekah, the covenant line continues

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 87 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 23:1-24:67. This is a Long reading covering Sarah's death and burial, then the extended narrative of finding a wife for Isaac. Read steadily; do not get bogged down in the details of negotiation. The heart of these chapters is the careful preservation of the covenant line.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Twenty-five years after the call, ten years after Isaac's birth, Sarah dies at 127. Abraham, now 137, buries her in a cave he purchases from the Hittites. This is the first piece of the promised land that the patriarchal family actually owns. Then attention turns to the next generation: a wife must be found for Isaac, and it must not be a Canaanite woman. Abraham sends his trusted servant on a journey to find a wife from his own people. The result is the beautiful story of Rebekah, and the covenant line continues.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Abraham bargains carefully and pays full price (400 shekels of silver) for the cave of Machpelah. The land is legally his.
2. Genesis 24 is the longest single chapter in Genesis, the longest piece of patriarchal narrative.
3. Abraham makes the servant swear by placing his hand under Abraham's thigh, a solemn oath, perhaps connected to circumcision.
4. The servant prays specifically for guidance and asks for a sign, and God answers his prayer before he finishes.

5. Rebekah's offer to water the camels (each drinks 20+ gallons) is the sign of her generous, hospitable character.
6. The servant attributes everything to God: "the LORD has led me" (verse 27), "the LORD has prospered my way" (verse 56).
7. Rebekah is asked, not commanded, whether she will go. Her "I will go" echoes Abraham's earlier obedience.
8. Isaac is meditating in the field at evening when Rebekah arrives. The covenant line is renewed in the next generation.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 23 and 24 are quiet chapters compared to what has come before. There is no dramatic test like Moriah, no destruction like Sodom. But they are essential to the story. Sarah dies, the first ancestor of Israel to be buried in the land of promise. And Isaac is given a wife, ensuring that the covenant line will continue.

The death of Sarah is significant. Abraham, who had been promised the land of Canaan as an everlasting possession, owns nothing in it until now. He must buy a cave from the Hittites to bury his wife. The chapter records the negotiation with great care, Abraham insists on paying full price, refusing the offer of a gift. He wants legal title. This is the first piece of the promised land that actually belongs to Abraham's family, and it is, ironically, a grave. The patriarchs will own the land as dead before they possess it as living. Their tombs become the down payment on the inheritance.

Genesis 24 then turns to the future. Abraham is concerned that Isaac not marry a Canaanite woman. The covenant family must remain distinct. So he sends his servant on a long journey back to Mesopotamia to find a wife from his own people. This is not about ethnic purity for its own sake. It is about preserving a household where the LORD will be known and the covenant will be lived out.

The chapter is remarkable for how prominently prayer features. The servant prays for guidance. He asks for a specific sign. And God answers, before the prayer is even finished, Rebekah appears. Notice how the servant attributes everything to God. He does not boast about his own perceptiveness. He says the LORD has led him, the LORD has prospered his way, the LORD has shown steadfast love. This is what biblical providence looks like in practice. A person walks in obedience, prays for guidance, and recognizes God's hand in what happens.

Rebekah is presented as the ideal partner for Isaac. She is generous, watering ten thirsty camels is no small thing. She is hospitable, inviting strangers to her family's home. She is courageous, willing to leave her home and travel to a husband she has never met. And critically, she is willing. When her family asks if she will go, she says, "I will go." Her words echo Abraham's response decades earlier: he went, when called. Now she goes, when called. The pattern of faith is repeating in a new generation.

The chapter ends with Isaac meditating in the field at evening. He looks up and sees the camels coming. Rebekah looks up and sees Isaac. They marry, and Isaac loves her. The covenant line continues. The promise is being passed to the next generation, not by accident or by mere biological succession, but by the careful providence of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Sarah's burial and Isaac's marriage are two halves of the same theme: the covenant line is being preserved across generations. The cave of Machpelah will eventually receive Abraham, Isaac, Rebekah, Jacob, and Leah, the first lasting presence of the covenant family in the promised land. And Rebekah's "I will go" echoes Abraham's call, preparing us for Jacob and Joseph and all who will follow in the line of faith.

STEP 6

Application

The covenant family is preserved through ordinary obedience and prayer. The servant in Genesis 24 is a model. He prays for guidance. He walks in obedience. He recognizes God's hand. He attributes every success to the LORD. Today, take his pattern with you. Pray about the decisions in front of you, however small. Walk in obedience. When good things happen, name them as gifts. The Christian life is largely the daily, quiet practice of trusting God's providence in unremarkable circumstances.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the quiet faithfulness that carried his promises forward.

Ask him to help you pray for guidance and see his hand in ordinary things.

Pray for the next generation of believers around you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 6

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

DAY 41 · WEEK 6

Genesis 25:1-26:35

Abraham's death; Jacob and Esau; Isaac's covenant renewed

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 25:1-26:35. The first chapter records Abraham's death and the birth of Jacob and Esau. The second focuses on Isaac, his struggles with the Philistines, the renewal of the covenant to him, and Esau's marriage to Hittite women. Watch for how the patterns of Abraham's life are repeating in Isaac's.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Abraham is 175 when he dies, having lived to see Isaac married and the covenant pass to the next generation. After his death, the story narrows to Isaac. Isaac is in many ways the quietest of the patriarchs, there are fewer dramatic episodes in his life than in his father's or his son's. But this chapter shows that the covenant continues to operate. Isaac and Rebekah struggle with infertility, just as Abraham and Sarah did. Twins are born, Esau and Jacob. And the same kinds of trials and blessings that marked Abraham's life now mark Isaac's.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Abraham takes another wife, Keturah, and has more children, but Isaac alone inherits everything (25:5).
2. Abraham dies "in a good old age, an old man and full of years", the first peaceful death in the Bible.
3. Isaac and Ishmael bury Abraham together at Machpelah. Family reconciliation at the grave.
4. Rebekah is barren for twenty years. Isaac prays for her, and she conceives.
5. Two nations struggle in Rebekah's womb. God tells her: "the older shall serve the younger."

6. Esau sells his birthright for stew. The text notes: “Thus Esau despised his birthright.”
7. Genesis 26 echoes Abraham’s life in striking ways: famine, deception about a wife being a sister, conflict over wells.
8. God renews the covenant to Isaac: “I will multiply your offspring… in your offspring all the nations of the earth shall be blessed.”
9. Esau marries two Hittite women, causing grief to Isaac and Rebekah.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 25 and 26 mark a transition. The Abraham era ends; the Isaac era begins. But the patterns continue. The covenant promises are renewed. The same struggles arise. The same faithfulness of God is displayed.

Abraham’s death is significant in its peacefulness. He is described as dying “in a good old age, an old man and full of years, and was gathered to his people.” This is the first instance in Scripture of the phrase “gathered to his people”, language that suggests something more than mere burial, perhaps anticipating the reunion of the patriarchs in the life to come. Abraham’s death is not tragic but full. He has seen the promise begin to be fulfilled, and he dies in peace.

The mention of Ishmael at the burial is touching. Isaac and Ishmael, half-brothers long separated by Sarah’s demand and Hagar’s exile, come together at their father’s grave. Death often brings reconciliation. The covenant blessing passes to Isaac, but the brotherly bond between the two sons is recognized at this moment.

Then attention shifts to Isaac and Rebekah. They have been married for twenty years without children. The pattern of barrenness is repeating, the same struggle Sarah faced. The covenant family seems perpetually on the edge of extinction, and God always answers prayer just in time. Isaac prays. Rebekah conceives.

But the pregnancy is difficult. Twins are wrestling inside her. She inquires of the LORD, and God reveals the future: “Two nations are in your womb… and the older shall serve the younger.” This is the doctrine of election in narrative form. Before either child has done anything good or bad, God has chosen the younger over the older. Paul will pick this up in Romans 9 as a key proof text for God’s sovereign election. The blessing does not flow by birth order. It flows by God’s choice.

Esau and Jacob are born. Esau, the elder, becomes a man of the field, a skilled hunter, his father’s favorite. Jacob, the younger, dwells in tents and is his mother’s favorite. The stage is set for the conflict that will dominate the rest of Genesis.

The famous birthright episode shows the contrast in character. Esau comes in from the field hungry. He sees Jacob's stew. He demands it. Jacob, calculating and opportunistic, offers it in exchange for the birthright. Esau swears, eats, and goes on his way. The text's verdict is brief and damning: "Thus Esau despised his birthright." The blessing of God meant so little to him that he traded it for a meal. Hebrews 12 will hold this up as a warning to believers: do not be like Esau, who sold his blessing for a single meal.

Genesis 26 then echoes Abraham's life in striking ways. Famine drives Isaac to Gerar, the same place his father went. Isaac lies about Rebekah, calling her his sister, the same lie his father told twice. Abimelech (or his successor) again deals with the patriarch's deception. Isaac digs wells; the Philistines stop them up; conflict ensues. The patterns are remarkably similar.

But God renews the covenant to Isaac. "I will be with you and will bless you… and I will establish the oath that I swore to Abraham your father. I will multiply your offspring as the stars of heaven… and in your offspring all the nations of the earth shall be blessed." The promise made to Abraham now belongs to Isaac. The covenant is generational. It does not stop with one person; it is passed to the next.

The chapter ends with a quiet sorrow: Esau marries two Hittite women, against the covenant pattern of marrying within the covenant family. The choices of Esau will have consequences for centuries to come.

STEP 5

Connection

The covenant passes from Abraham to Isaac. The same pattern that marked Abraham, barrenness then miraculous birth, famine then provision, deception then divine protection, now marks Isaac. And the line of promise continues to narrow: not all of Isaac's children, but Jacob in particular, will carry the covenant forward. Romans 9 will return to this chapter to show that God's saving purposes operate by election, not by ethnic descent.

STEP 6

Application

Two warnings emerge from these chapters. First, do not despise your birthright. Whatever spiritual blessings God has given you, your salvation, your church, your access to Scripture, your privileged knowledge of the gospel, do not trade them for cheap satisfactions. Esau sold his birthright for stew because the stew was tangible and the birthright was not. Watch out for the daily temptation to trade eternal goods for momentary pleasures.

Second, take heart that God is faithful across generations. The covenant did not stop with Abraham. It passed to Isaac. The God who blessed your spiritual parents and grandparents is the God who blesses you, and who will bless your children if you walk in faith. The covenant is generational. Your faithfulness today shapes the spiritual inheritance of those who come after you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for carrying his covenant across generations to you.

Confess where you have despised something precious for something immediate.

Ask him to help you pass the faith to someone who comes after you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 6

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

DAY 42 · WEEK 6

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. The week you have completed contained the binding of Isaac on Mount Moriah, one of the most theologically loaded chapters in the entire Old Testament. Take time today to let the depth of Abraham's faith, and the foreshadowing of Christ's sacrifice, settle in you.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

REST

Meditation

Genesis 15:6 is the single most important Old Testament verse for understanding the New Testament's doctrine of salvation. Paul quotes it in Romans 4 and Galatians 3 as the proof that justification has always been by faith, never by works.

Three things are happening here. Abraham believed, faith is the means, not earning. The LORD counted, the accounting is divine, not human. And what was counted was righteousness, not credit toward future righteousness, but righteousness itself.

Say the verse and notice: Abraham did nothing to earn this. He had lied about Sarai. He would lie again. He had not yet been circumcised. He had not yet faced Moriah. And he was reckoned righteous on the basis of believing. This is grace. This is also the verdict over you, if you have believed in Christ. Carry the verse with you as the legal verdict over your life. You are reckoned righteous, not because of who you are, but because of who Christ is.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

The week began with Abraham's bold intercession for Sodom and the contrasting end of Lot's compromised life. It moved through the long-awaited birth of Isaac, Sarah's laughter, the fulfillment of twenty-five years of waiting. Then came Genesis 22, the binding of Isaac. The mountain of Moriah. The wood carried by the son. The ram caught in the thicket. The substitute provided by God. You worshiped with Psalm 105:23-45, which carried the patriarchal story forward into the Exodus. You watched Sarah die and Isaac receive Rebekah. And the week closed with the birth of Jacob and Esau, and the long pattern of the unloved younger son being chosen by God.

The week was about tested faith. Faith that lies sometimes. Faith that laughs in disbelief and then in fulfillment. Faith that climbs the mountain with the knife. Faith that, in spite of all its weakness, is reckoned as righteousness.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

What is your Isaac? Genesis 22 asks every believer this question eventually: what has God given you that you would struggle to give back to him? Name it today. Hold it loosely. The God who tested Abraham is the same God who did not spare his own Son. He has already given his most. Trust him with yours.

How does the binding of Isaac point you to the cross? Every detail of Genesis 22 anticipates Calvary, the beloved son carrying wood up the hill, the substitute provided by God, the son spared because another died. But at Moriah, the son was spared. At Calvary, the Son was not. Why does this matter? Sit with the difference today. How does the cross deepen your reading of Abraham's near-sacrifice?

Where is your faith being tested right now, and what does Genesis 15:6 say to you in the test? Faith is not the absence of weakness. Abraham was reckoned righteous even with his lies still ahead of him. If you have believed in Christ, his righteousness has been reckoned to you, and that verdict holds even when your faith feels small.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that your standing with him is righteous in Christ, not good enough by your own effort.

Ask him to show you what you are holding too tightly and to help you hold it loosely.

Thank Jesus for carrying the wood and not being spared.

DAY 43 · WEEK 7

Genesis 27:1-28:22

The stolen blessing; Jacob's ladder, election and promise

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 67 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 27:1-28:22. These chapters tell the story of Jacob stealing Esau's blessing, his flight from his brother's wrath, and his vision of the ladder at Bethel. Notice the messiness of God's election, Jacob is a deceiver, and yet God claims him as the bearer of the covenant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaac is old and nearly blind. He plans to bless Esau, his favorite son, before he dies. But Rebekah overhears and concocts a scheme: Jacob will pretend to be Esau and steal the blessing. The deception works. When Esau discovers it, he plans to kill Jacob, so Jacob flees to Rebekah's family in the east. On the way, he has a dream, the famous vision of the ladder reaching to heaven, with angels ascending and descending, and the LORD himself standing above. This is one of the most theologically rich dreams in the Old Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Isaac wants to bless Esau, his favorite, despite God's word that the older would serve the younger.
2. Rebekah's deception is elaborate, goat skins on Jacob's hands, Esau's clothes on his body, savory food disguised as game.
3. Isaac is suspicious but ultimately deceived. He blesses Jacob, thinking he is Esau.
4. Esau's grief is real and intense: "Bless me, even me also, O my father!" He weeps bitterly.
5. Isaac's second blessing on Esau is much weaker, Esau will live by the sword and serve his brother.

6. Esau plans to kill Jacob “as soon as Father is dead.” Murderous intent toward a brother, echoes of Cain.
7. Jacob flees to Haran, sent by his parents on the pretext of finding a wife.
8. On the way, alone in the wilderness, Jacob has the dream of the ladder.
9. The angels ascend and descend on the ladder. The LORD stands above and renews the covenant promise.
10. Jacob’s response: “Surely the LORD is in this place, and I did not know it.” Awe meets reality.
11. He names the place Bethel (“house of God”) and vows that if God brings him back safely, the LORD will be his God.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 27 and 28 are a study in the messiness of God’s election. Jacob is not a hero. He is a deceiver, manipulating his blind father, profiting from his mother’s scheme, stealing what God had already chosen to give him. And yet God meets him on the run and renews the covenant. This is the doctrine of grace in narrative form. God’s choice does not wait for moral worthiness. It operates on the basis of his own purposes.

The deception in Genesis 27 is excruciating to read. Rebekah, who knew from the womb that Jacob would be the chosen one, does not trust God to bring it about. So she takes matters into her own hands. She prepares the deception. She gives Jacob detailed instructions. She even takes the blame herself: “Let your curse be on me, my son.” Jacob, more cautious than committed, hesitates only because he might get caught, not because the deception is wrong. The scheme works. Isaac is fooled. Jacob receives the blessing meant for Esau.

The aftermath is devastating. Esau returns with the game he had hunted. Isaac trembles when he realizes what has happened. Esau cries out, one of the most painful cries in Scripture: “Bless me, even me also, O my father!” Hebrews 12 records what happened next: “He found no chance to repent, though he sought it with tears.” The blessing once given could not be undone. Isaac speaks a secondary, lesser blessing over Esau, but the primary blessing is gone.

And then comes the consequence. Esau plans to kill Jacob. Rebekah, learning of this, sends Jacob away. The mother who manipulated to get her son the blessing now loses him, perhaps forever, the text suggests she never sees him again. The patriarchal family is fractured by deceit. Jacob flees with nothing but his staff. His scheming has cost him home, mother, father, and brother.

But God meets him on the road. In the wilderness, alone, with a stone for a pillow, Jacob has the dream. A ladder is set up between earth and heaven. The angels of God are ascending and descending on it. And the LORD stands above the ladder and speaks: "I am the LORD, the God of Abraham your father and the God of Isaac... and in you and your offspring shall all the families of the earth be blessed."

The covenant has just been renewed, to Jacob the deceiver, on the run, with nothing to commend him. This is grace. The same God who chose Jacob in the womb is choosing Jacob still. The promises made to Abraham, renewed to Isaac, are now passed to Jacob. The man does not deserve them. God gives them anyway. That is the definition of grace.

The image of the ladder is rich. It is the meeting place of heaven and earth. Angels move between the two realms. The God who seemed distant when Jacob fled is right above him. Centuries later, Jesus will tell Nathanael, "You will see heaven opened, and the angels of God ascending and descending on the Son of Man" (John 1:51). Jesus is the true ladder. He is the meeting place of heaven and earth. The dream Jacob saw was a preview of the incarnation. Jesus is the ladder that brings heaven down to those who are running from their own messes.

Jacob's response is awe. "Surely the LORD is in this place, and I did not know it... This is none other than the house of God, and this is the gate of heaven." He renames the place Bethel, "house of God." And he makes a vow: "If God will be with me and will keep me... then the LORD shall be my God." It is a tentative response, half faith, half bargaining. Jacob is not yet the man he will become. But God has met him, and the journey toward transformation has begun.

STEP 5

Connection

The covenant has now been renewed to all three patriarchs, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Each time, God renews it freely, despite the failures of the recipients. Jacob's ladder will become one of the great Christological images of the Old Testament: Jesus is the true ladder, the meeting place of heaven and earth, the one in whom the promises to Abraham finally find their fulfillment.

STEP 6

Application

If God only worked through moral heroes, none of us would qualify. Jacob was a manipulator. Rebekah was a schemer. Isaac was favoring the wrong son. Esau was profane. And in the middle of this dysfunctional family, God's grace ran on, choosing, renewing, blessing. Today, take comfort from the fact that the God of Jacob is the God of imperfect

people. He is not waiting for you to clean up your act before he meets you on the road. He is the God who shows up at Bethel, wherever you are, however you got there, with whatever stones you have for pillows. Look up. The ladder is open. Christ is the meeting place. And the same covenant promises are spoken over you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he meets imperfect people on the run, and tell him where you have been running.

Thank Christ as the true ladder between heaven and earth.

Ask him to speak to you in your own wilderness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 7

"Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

GENESIS 28:15

DAY 44 · WEEK 7

Genesis 29:1-30:43

Jacob with Laban; the twelve sons; God's providence

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 29:1-30:43. Jacob arrives in Haran, meets Rachel, works for Laban, gets deceived into marrying Leah, marries Rachel as well, and fathers eleven of the twelve tribes of Israel. This is a long, complicated, messy stretch, but it is also the formation of the people of God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jacob arrives in Haran and meets Rachel at the well. He falls in love with her and agrees to work seven years for Laban as a bride price. Laban, every bit as crafty as Jacob, substitutes Leah on the wedding night. Jacob discovers the deception in the morning but must work another seven years to also marry Rachel. What follows is the painful, fertile, complicated story of how the twelve sons of Jacob, the fathers of the twelve tribes of Israel, were born. It is a story of sibling rivalry, jealousy, manipulation, and the slow forming of a nation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Jacob meets Rachel at a well, echoing his father's servant meeting Rebekah at a well.
2. Jacob falls in love at first sight and agrees to seven years of work as a bride price. The text says it seemed to him "but a few days because of the love he had for her."
3. Laban switches Leah for Rachel on the wedding night. Jacob, the deceiver, is deceived. Poetic justice.
4. Jacob must work seven more years for Rachel, but receives her immediately after the bridal week.
5. Leah is unloved but fertile; Rachel is loved but barren. The pattern of barrenness continues with the matriarchs.

6. Leah names her first four sons with theological intent: Reuben ("the LORD has seen"), Simeon ("the LORD has heard"), Levi ("attached"), Judah ("praise").
7. Bilhah and Zilpah, the maidservants, are given as concubines, a repetition of the Hagar mistake on a larger scale.
8. Twelve sons (and one daughter, Dinah) are born across the four mothers, the future twelve tribes of Israel.
9. Jacob and Laban's economic struggle (chapter 30:25-43) shows God blessing Jacob despite Laban's repeated manipulations.

STEP 4

Interpretation

These two chapters cover roughly twenty years of Jacob's life, his years in Haran working for Laban, marrying both Leah and Rachel, and fathering the children who would become the twelve tribes of Israel. It is a long, painful, fertile period. And in the midst of all the dysfunction, God is forming a nation.

When Jacob arrives in Haran, he meets Rachel at a well. This is a deliberate echo of how Isaac's bride was found. The God who meets the covenant family at wells is providentially arranging marriages and futures. Jacob falls instantly in love with Rachel. He agrees to seven years of work for her hand. The text says it seemed to him "but a few days because of the love he had for her", one of the most romantic lines in the Bible.

But Laban is every bit as cunning as Jacob. On the wedding night, Laban substitutes Leah (the older sister) for Rachel. Jacob does not realize until the morning. The deception is shocking. The same Jacob who pretended to be Esau by wearing hairy goat skins is now deceived by a woman wearing a wedding veil. The deceiver is deceived. This is one of the Bible's clearest examples of divine justice working through ordinary circumstances. What Jacob did to Esau and Isaac, Laban now does to him. He reaps what he sowed.

But there is more here. The substitution of Leah for Rachel, the unloved sister for the loved one, sets up one of the great tensions of the rest of Genesis. Leah is "not loved" by Jacob (the Hebrew is striking, "hated" is too strong but "less loved" is too soft). And yet God sees her. He opens her womb while Rachel remains barren. Leah's first four sons are named with such theological intent: Reuben means "the LORD has seen my affliction." Simeon means "the LORD has heard that I am hated." Levi means "attached" (perhaps hoping Jacob will be attached to her). Judah means "praise", by the fourth son, Leah stops naming her babies in relation to her husband and starts naming them in praise to God. This is a profound shift. She has learned to find her satisfaction in the LORD rather than in the love of her husband.

And critically, it is Leah, not Rachel, who becomes the mother of Judah. Judah will be the tribe of David. Judah will be the tribe of Christ. The "loved" wife was barren; the "unloved" wife bore the line of Messiah. This is grace's preference for the overlooked.

The two maidservants, Bilhah and Zilpah, are then given to Jacob as concubines. This is a repetition of the Hagar mistake at a larger scale. Just as Sarah tried to fulfill the promise through Hagar, Rachel and Leah try to compete with each other through their servants. The result is twelve sons born across four mothers, in a household full of jealousy and rivalry. This is hardly the picture of a holy family. And yet, these twelve sons will become the twelve tribes of Israel. God forms the nation through this dysfunctional household.

Genesis 30 ends with a long economic conflict between Jacob and Laban. Laban has been cheating Jacob for years. Now Jacob, in turn, engineers a complicated breeding scheme that results in his flocks growing rapidly while Laban's diminish. The text is careful to note that God is the one prospering Jacob, but Jacob is hardly innocent in his methods. The two crafty men are locked in a battle of wits, and God uses it to make Jacob prosperous so he can eventually leave Haran with the resources to start a new life.

STEP 5

Connection

The twelve sons of Jacob are the foundation of the nation of Israel. The twelve tribes named in this chapter, Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Dan, Naphtali, Gad, Asher, Issachar, Zebulun, Joseph, Benjamin (born later), will become the structure of Israel for the next thousand years. Judah, in particular, will become the tribe of David, and from Judah will come Christ. The unloved wife Leah is therefore the great-great-grandmother of the Messiah. God's redemptive plan ran through the despised.

STEP 6

Application

If God can form his people out of this household, full of deception, jealousy, polygamy, and rivalry, he can form his people out of anything. Take heart if your own family or community feels too broken for God to use. Take heart if you yourself feel too tangled to be useful. The God of Jacob is the God of complicated stories. He works with what is, not with idealizations of what should be.

And if you feel unloved or overlooked, like Leah, remember that she is the one through whom Christ came. God sees those who are not seen by the world. He gives praise to the lips of those who have been demoted by others. The line that mattered most ran through her, not through the favored sister.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that no family story is too tangled for him to redeem, and name one in your own life.

Ask him to help you see and care for the overlooked as he did.

Tell him what you want to praise him for, as Leah learned to.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 7

"Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

GENESIS 28:15

DAY 45 · WEEK 7

Psalm 121

The LORD is your keeper, the pilgrim's confidence

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 121 twice. This is one of the most beloved psalms in the Bible, the second of the Psalms of Ascent, sung by pilgrims journeying up to Jerusalem. It is a perfect psalm for Jacob's journey, and for yours.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 121 belongs to a group of fifteen psalms (Psalms 120-134) called the Psalms of Ascent. These were sung by Jewish pilgrims as they traveled up to Jerusalem for the great feasts. They are psalms of the road, of journey, danger, trust, and arrival. Psalm 121 specifically is a meditation on God as the keeper of his people on their pilgrimage. After several days walking through the Jacob narrative, the deceiver fleeing from home, traveling alone, having visions and disputes, this psalm is the appropriate pause. It teaches us how to pray as we travel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 1: "I lift up my eyes to the hills. From where does my help come?" The hills could be a source of danger or a reminder of God's dwelling.
2. Verse 2 answers: "My help comes from the LORD, who made heaven and earth." The Creator is the keeper.
3. The word "keep" (Hebrew shamar) appears six times in eight verses, it is the spine of the psalm.
4. Verse 3: "He will not let your foot be moved; he who keeps you will not slumber." Constant vigilance.
5. Verse 4 expands: "Behold, he who keeps Israel will neither slumber nor sleep." God never rests off duty.

6. Verse 5: “The LORD is your keeper; the LORD is your shade on your right hand.” Protective presence.
7. Verses 7-8: “The LORD will keep you from all evil; he will keep your life. The LORD will keep your going out and your coming in, from this time forth and forevermore.” All-encompassing protection.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 121 is the song of the pilgrim. It begins with a question, “From where does my help come?”, and answers it definitively. Help comes from the LORD, the maker of heaven and earth. Everything else in the psalm flows from that initial confession.

The word that holds the psalm together is “keep”, shamar in Hebrew. It appears six times in just eight verses. The LORD keeps you. He keeps Israel. He keeps your life. He keeps your going out and your coming in. The psalm is essentially a meditation on the fact that God is the keeper of his people. He does not just save them; he keeps them. Salvation is the moment of rescue; keeping is the long, daily, faithful work of preservation that follows.

The psalm makes striking claims about God’s keeping. He will not let your foot be moved. He will not slumber. He will not sleep. These are claims about the unceasing vigilance of God. In a world where every other guardian eventually fails, sleeps, dies, looks away, God never does. The keeper of Israel is awake right now. The keeper of Israel is awake while you sleep. The keeper of Israel is awake when you are unconscious in surgery, when you are flying across oceans, when you are walking through your worst day. He never slumbers.

Verse 5 introduces a beautiful image: “The LORD is your shade on your right hand.” In the ancient Near East, shade was life. The sun beat down relentlessly, and shade was the difference between survival and death. God is shade, the merciful protection that makes life possible. And he is on your right hand, the closest position, the most attentive position.

The psalm closes with a promise that extends in every direction. The LORD will keep you from all evil. He will keep your life. He will keep your going out and your coming in. Every direction of travel, every threshold you cross, every door you walk through, God keeps. And the time frame is total: from this time forth and forevermore. The keeping does not end. Even death does not interrupt it. The same God who keeps you now will keep you through your final breath and into the life to come.

STEP 5

Connection

Jacob, fleeing from Esau, alone in the wilderness, dreamed of a ladder and heard the covenant promise renewed. Now he is on the long pilgrimage of Genesis 29-31, journeying through years of hard labor and difficult relationships. This psalm could have been his, a song for the pilgrim, sung by anyone who is walking through uncertain seasons. And it is yours, too. The God who kept Jacob is the God who keeps you.

STEP 6

Application

Today, lift your eyes. Wherever you are, whatever you are facing, lift your eyes from the immediate to the eternal. Your help is not in your own resources, your own planning, your own strength. Your help comes from the LORD, the maker of heaven and earth. The same God who flung galaxies into space is keeping you right now. He has not slumbered. He has not slept. His shade is on your right hand at this very moment.

And take comfort that God keeps "your going out and your coming in." This is total coverage. The mundane comings and goings of your day, the commute to work, the trip to the grocery store, the school pickup, the walk to the mailbox, all of it is under his keeping. There are no insignificant moments to a God who keeps every coming and going. He is involved in your whole life, not just the dramatic parts. Receive his keeping today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Lift your eyes to God and tell him where you need help today.
- Thank him that he never slumbers and is keeping you right now.
- Ask him to keep your going out and your coming in.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 7

"Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

GENESIS 28:15

DAY 46 · WEEK 7

Psalm 124; Psalm 125

If the LORD had not been on our side

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 124 and Psalm 125 slowly, twice. Both are Psalms of Ascent. Psalm 124 looks back at past deliverance; Psalm 125 looks forward in confident trust. Together they are the song of those who have walked through hardship and arrived at certainty about who God is.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

We continue the Psalms of Ascent. Psalm 124 is attributed to David and reflects on what would have happened to Israel if the LORD had not been on their side. Psalm 125 then offers confident trust, those who trust in the LORD are like Mount Zion, which cannot be moved. Together they capture both the memory and the hope of God's people. They are perfect songs for those who have made it through difficulty and are walking by faith toward the future.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Psalm 124 opens with a hypothetical: "If it had not been the LORD who was on our side…", followed by vivid pictures of what would have happened.
2. The threats described are dramatic: men rising up, being swallowed alive, the floods sweeping us away, the torrent going over our soul.
3. Verse 6 turns to praise: "Blessed be the LORD, who has not given us as prey to their teeth!"
4. The bird-and-snare image (verse 7) captures the suddenness of God's deliverance.
5. The psalm closes with the same confession as Psalm 121:2, "Our help is in the name of the LORD, who made heaven and earth."

6. Psalm 125:1 opens with a simile: “Those who trust in the LORD are like Mount Zion, which cannot be moved.”
7. Verse 2: “As the mountains surround Jerusalem, so the LORD surrounds his people, from this time forth and forevermore.”
8. The psalm acknowledges the threat of evil (the “scepter of wickedness”) but promises it will not “rest on the land allotted to the righteous.”
9. It closes with the prayer: “Peace be upon Israel!”

STEP 4

Interpretation

These two short psalms complement one another. The first remembers past rescue. The second confidently anticipates future stability. Together they form the bipolar prayer of the believer: gratitude for what God has done, confidence in what God will do.

Psalm 124 begins with one of the most striking rhetorical devices in the Psalter. “If it had not been the LORD who was on our side…” And then the psalmist runs through the disasters that would have followed: enemies would have swallowed them alive, floods would have swept them away, torrents would have gone over their souls. The whole psalm is built on the contrary-to-fact conditional. If God had not acted, this would have happened. But God did act, and so we are here, singing.

This is one of the most important habits the believer can cultivate. Look back at your life and ask, Where did God intervene? Where did things turn out differently than they could have? The Christian’s memory is not random. It is curated by the Spirit to recall the acts of God. Every time you remember a deliverance, you are doing what Psalm 124 does. You are putting words to what would have been, in order to celebrate what is.

The bird-and-snare image of verse 7 is one of the most evocative pictures of rescue in the Psalter. “We have escaped like a bird from the snare of the fowlers; the snare is broken, and we have escaped!” Anyone who has ever felt trapped, by sin, by circumstance, by fear, by depression, knows what this image describes. The snare is real. The bird really is caught. And then suddenly the snare breaks and the bird is in the air. That is what salvation feels like.

Psalm 125 then turns to the future. “Those who trust in the LORD are like Mount Zion, which cannot be moved, but abides forever.” This is a remarkable promise. Those who trust in the LORD are themselves like Mount Zion, solid, enduring, eternal. Their faith is not just an internal feeling; it produces a kind of life that cannot be shaken. They become, in their very being, immovable.

And the image expands. “As the mountains surround Jerusalem, so the LORD surrounds his people.” Jerusalem is in the Judean hills, ringed by mountains on every side. The natural fortification was significant in ancient warfare. But the psalmist says God himself is the surrounding mountains around his people. Wherever the LORD’s people are, they are surrounded by his presence and protection. And this surrounding is permanent: from this time forth and forevermore.

The psalm is realistic about evil. The “scepter of wickedness” does come upon the land. But it will not rest there permanently. And the psalm closes with the simplest of prayers: “Peace be upon Israel!” Shalom, wholeness, flourishing, the fullness of God’s blessing.

STEP 5

Connection

The Psalms of Ascent fit naturally with Jacob’s life. His life has been a pilgrimage, flight from home, years in Haran, return to Canaan, descent into Egypt to come. The believer’s life is similarly a pilgrimage. We are journeying through this age toward our true home. These psalms teach us how to walk: looking back in gratitude, looking forward in trust, surrounded by the presence of the LORD.

STEP 6

Application

Practice two habits today. First, the habit of Psalm 124: look back. Take a few minutes today to remember one specific way God intervened in your life. Maybe it was a near accident avoided. Maybe it was a relationship saved. Maybe it was a sin you almost committed but didn’t. Maybe it was a prayer answered just in time. Name it. Thank him for it. Tell someone about it.

Second, the habit of Psalm 125: trust. Receive the promise that you, trusting in the LORD, are like Mount Zion. You cannot be ultimately shaken. The same mountains that surround Jerusalem are the encircling presence of God around your life. Whatever feels unstable today, your foundation is not. Pray Psalm 125 over yourself: I trust in the LORD. I am like Mount Zion. He surrounds me. Peace be upon me, in his name.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bless the LORD for a time he did not let you be overwhelmed, and tell him about it.

Thank him for the snares he has broken in your life.

Ask him to make your trust as settled as the mountains that surround Jerusalem.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 7

“Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go.”

GENESIS 28:15

DAY 47 · WEEK 7

Genesis 31:1-32:32

Jacob departs Laban; wrestling with God at Jabbok

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 75 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 31:1-32:32. Jacob finally leaves Laban, faces him in a confrontation, and then prepares to meet Esau. The chapter climaxes with the famous wrestling match at the Jabbok, where Jacob becomes Israel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jacob has spent twenty years working for Laban. Now the LORD tells him to return to the land of his fathers. He leaves secretly, taking his wives, children, and flocks. Laban pursues, the two confront one another, and they part with an uneasy treaty. But the bigger fear ahead is Esau. The brother Jacob deceived twenty years ago is on his way to meet him with four hundred men. The night before the meeting, Jacob is left alone, and there he wrestles with a mysterious man until dawn. The encounter changes everything.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God tells Jacob to return, verse 3: “Return to the land of your fathers and to your kindred, and I will be with you.”
2. Rachel steals her father’s household gods, an action Jacob does not know about, but which puts the family in danger.
3. Laban pursues, accuses, searches, and ultimately makes a treaty with Jacob. The mound of stones (Mizpah) is the witness.
4. Jacob then faces Esau. He prays, the first recorded prayer of Jacob (32:9-12), recalling God’s promise.
5. He sends elaborate gifts ahead to appease Esau. Practical wisdom alongside prayer.

6. Alone at night, he wrestles with a “man” until daybreak. The man cannot prevail by force but disables Jacob’s hip.
7. Jacob refuses to let go without a blessing. He gets one, and a new name: Israel (“he strives with God”).
8. Jacob names the place Peniel (“face of God”), “I have seen God face to face, and yet my life has been delivered.”
9. He walks away limping. The wound is permanent.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 32 contains one of the most mysterious and important events in the Old Testament. Jacob wrestles all night with a man who turns out to be God. He emerges with a new name, a permanent limp, and a new identity.

The chapter is set up by Jacob’s fear. He is returning to face the brother he deceived. He is convinced Esau will kill him. So he prepares in three ways. First, he prays, the first recorded prayer of Jacob in Scripture, and it is full of acknowledged unworthiness: “I am not worthy of the least of all the deeds of steadfast love and all the faithfulness that you have shown to your servant.” Twenty years of dealing with Laban have humbled Jacob. He is no longer the confident schemer of Genesis 27. Second, he sends gifts ahead, wave after wave of livestock, to soften Esau’s heart. Third, he divides his family into two camps, so that if one is attacked, the other might escape.

Then night falls, and Jacob is left alone. A man comes and wrestles him until dawn. The text is deliberately ambiguous at first about who this man is. He is strong but cannot prevail by force. He touches Jacob’s hip and dislocates it. He pleads to be released as dawn breaks. Jacob refuses unless he receives a blessing. The man asks for Jacob’s name, and Jacob, for the first time honestly, admits “Jacob.” The name means “deceiver, supplanter.” Jacob is finally confessing who he has been.

And the man renames him. “Your name shall no longer be called Jacob, but Israel, for you have striven with God and with men, and have prevailed.” Israel means “he strives with God” or “God strives.” Jacob’s identity is fundamentally remade. The deceiver becomes the striver. The man who has spent his life manipulating now becomes the man who wrestles God face to face.

Jacob asks the man’s name. The man does not give it. Instead, he blesses Jacob and departs. Jacob, awestruck, names the place Peniel, “face of God”, and says, “I have seen God face to face, and yet my life has been delivered.” This was no ordinary man. This was the LORD himself, in some form that allowed face-to-face encounter without destroying Jacob.

And Jacob walks away limping. The wound is permanent. From this night forward, his body bears the mark of his wrestling with God. The point is profound. Encounter with God always leaves a mark. You do not walk away from God unchanged. The limp is not weakness; it is testimony. Every step Jacob takes for the rest of his life is a reminder that he met God and lived.

STEP 5

Connection

Jacob the deceiver becomes Israel, the name his descendants will bear for all of history. The covenant family now has its national name. And the wrestling at Peniel is a vivid picture of the believer's relationship with God: it is a struggle, but it is also intimate; it is wounding, but it is also blessing; it leaves us limping, but it gives us a new identity.

STEP 6

Application

Have you wrestled with God? Not in the casual sense, but in the deep sense, staying with him in prayer even when it feels like fighting, holding on for a blessing you cannot articulate, refusing to let go until something is changed in you. This is what serious prayer becomes for the maturing believer. It is not always pleasant. It may leave you limping. But it gives you a new name. Today, if there is something you have been wrestling with God about, a fear, a calling, a relationship, a deep question about your own identity, do not let go. Hold on. The blessing comes at dawn.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God honestly where you need to wrestle with him, and what you want from him.
- Ask him to show you who he is making you to be.
- Ask him to help you walk in what you have met of him, even if it leaves a mark.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 7

"Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

GENESIS 28:15

DAY 48 · WEEK 7

Genesis 33:1-35:29

Reconciliation with Esau; Dinah; Bethel revisited

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 74 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 33:1-35:29. Jacob meets Esau and is received in unexpected love. Then comes the tragic Dinah episode. Then God calls Jacob back to Bethel, where the covenant is renewed and Rachel dies in childbirth.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The dreaded reunion with Esau is not what Jacob expected. Esau runs to meet him, embraces him, and weeps. The brothers reconcile, at least for the moment. But the next chapter is one of the most painful in Genesis: the rape of Dinah and the violent revenge of her brothers Simeon and Levi. After this disaster, God calls Jacob back to Bethel, where his journey began with the ladder vision. The covenant is renewed, and Rachel dies giving birth to Benjamin, the last of the twelve sons.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Esau runs to meet Jacob, embraces him, falls on his neck, and weeps. The reunion is more tender than Jacob expected.
2. Jacob calls Esau's face "like seeing the face of God", connecting the reconciliation to his Peniel encounter.
3. The brothers separate again. Reconciliation does not always mean continued closeness.
4. Dinah is raped by Shechem, son of the local ruler. The text is candid about the assault.
5. Simeon and Levi deceitfully arrange the circumcision of all the men, then attack while they are recovering. Mass murder.

6. Jacob rebukes them, but for pragmatic reasons, not moral ones. He fears retaliation, not the immorality of his sons.
7. God calls Jacob back to Bethel. He instructs the household to put away foreign gods, a partial reform.
8. The covenant is renewed at Bethel: "I am God Almighty: be fruitful and multiply." The Abrahamic promises are reaffirmed.
9. Rachel dies giving birth to Benjamin. She is buried near Bethlehem.
10. Isaac dies at the end of the chapter, and Esau and Jacob bury him together.

STEP 4

Interpretation

These three chapters cover a remarkable range, from joyful reunion to brutal violence to renewed covenant to family death. They are the swirling middle of Jacob's life.

The meeting with Esau confounds expectation. Jacob has been terrified for twenty years. He has prayed, sent gifts, divided his family. And Esau runs to him, embraces him, and weeps. The God who blessed Jacob at Peniel has also been at work in Esau. The brother Jacob defrauded has somehow let go of the wrong. They reconcile, at least for the moment. Notice Jacob's striking words: "I have seen your face, which is like seeing the face of God." Jacob is connecting his encounter with Esau to his encounter with God the night before. To see the face of someone you have wronged, and to be received in love, that is, in some sense, to see the face of God.

The brothers do not continue traveling together. Jacob declines Esau's invitation to live near him. Reconciliation does not always mean continued closeness. Sometimes the right thing after forgiveness is to let go and live separately. This is wisdom.

Genesis 34 is one of the hardest chapters in Genesis. Dinah, Jacob's only daughter, is raped by Shechem. Shechem then claims to love her and seeks marriage. Simeon and Levi, two of Dinah's brothers, deceive Shechem's people, telling them they will give Dinah in marriage if all the men of the city are circumcised. When the men are weakened and recovering from the procedure, Simeon and Levi attack and kill them all, plundering the city and taking the women and children captive. It is mass murder.

Jacob's response is notable for what it is not. He does not rebuke his sons for their wickedness, only for the danger they have put the family in. "You have brought trouble on me by making me stink to the inhabitants of the land." This is pragmatic concern, not moral

confrontation. Jacob's parenting failures are evident. His silence at moral evil, first with Dinah, now with the sons' revenge, will haunt the family for generations. Genesis 49 will record his deathbed cursing of Simeon and Levi's anger.

But God calls Jacob back to Bethel. The journey that began there twenty years ago must end there. Jacob instructs his household to put away foreign gods. This is a partial reform, Jacob's household has been carrying idols all this time, and only now does he address it. The text is honest about how slow holiness is, even in the chosen family.

At Bethel, God appears again and renews the covenant. The promises given to Abraham, renewed to Isaac, renewed to Jacob at the ladder, are renewed once more. The God who began with Jacob is faithful to finish.

Then Rachel dies giving birth to Benjamin. The beloved wife of Jacob, the woman he worked fourteen years for, dies in labor. She names her son Ben-Oni ("son of my sorrow"), but Jacob renames him Benjamin ("son of my right hand"). The grief of the family is real, but the line of promise continues. The twelfth son is born. The twelve tribes are now complete.

The chapter closes with Isaac's death and burial. Esau and Jacob bury their father together at Machpelah. The patriarchs are being gathered to their people one by one.

STEP 5

Connection

The renewal of the covenant at Bethel ties Jacob's life full circle. He left there a fleeing deceiver; he returns as a wrestling man with a new name. The covenant promises remain unchanged. And the twelve sons are now complete, the twelve tribes that will become Israel.

STEP 6

Application

Reconciliation is possible. The brother you cannot face today, the wound you cannot imagine being healed, God can do it. Esau forgave Jacob, and the impossibility became reality. But also, reconciliation does not always mean continued closeness. Sometimes wisdom is to forgive and live separately. Both are biblical. Both are valid.

And take seriously the cost of parental silence. Jacob did not confront the moral evil in his own sons, and the consequences echo for generations. If you have children, or have influence over young people, speak up. Not just about danger, but about wickedness itself. Silence at evil teaches the next generation that evil is acceptable.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bring a strained relationship to God, and ask what he would have you do.

Ask him for the courage to name wrong where you see it, in love.

Ask him to renew your commitment to him at the places you have wandered from.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 7

"Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

GENESIS 28:15

DAY 49 · WEEK 7

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. The week you have completed followed Jacob, the deceiver, through his deepest crisis and into his transformation. Take time today to sit with the God who meets his people on the run.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

GENESIS 28:15

REST

Meditation

Genesis 28:15 is the promise God spoke to Jacob at Bethel, to a man who had just deceived his father, stolen his brother's blessing, and was fleeing for his life. He had nothing to commend him to God. And God said: "I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

This is grace at its purest. The promise is not conditional on Jacob's behavior. It is unilateral. Notice the verbs, God will keep, God will bring, God will not leave. The promise rests entirely on God's faithfulness, not on Jacob's.

Say the verse to yourself. Hear the word "keep" as we heard it in Psalm 121 this week, the LORD as your keeper, never slumbering, watching over your going out and your coming in. Wherever you go, to work, into difficult relationships, into hard seasons, God is with you. By the end of this week, this verse should be your daily reminder that you are not alone.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

The week followed Jacob's whole arc. You read his stealing of Esau's blessing and his flight from home, and then the ladder vision at Bethel, where the covenant was renewed to a deceiver on the run. You watched him spend twenty years with Laban, marry Leah and Rachel, father eleven of the twelve tribes. You sang Psalm 121, the LORD as your keeper, and the Psalms of Ascent that followed. And then came Jacob's wrestling at Peniel, where he received a new name: Israel. And finally his reunion with Esau, where the brother he had wronged ran to him with embrace and tears.

The week's theme is transformation. Jacob the deceiver becomes Israel the striver. The man who manipulated for blessing learns to wrestle for it. And the God who began with him at Bethel keeps him through every twist of his road home.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where has God met you "on the run", in a season when you did not deserve it? Jacob was fleeing his consequences when God appeared at Bethel. Not as a reward for his obedience, but as grace in the middle of his failure. Name a moment in your own life when God met you despite you. How does that memory shape how you receive his grace today?

How does Jacob's wrestling at Peniel point you to Christ? Jacob wrestled with God and emerged with a new name, a permanent limp, and a blessing. The Christian's wrestling with God in prayer is not a struggle against an enemy but a struggle with a Father, and through Christ, every wrestling believer emerges with a new name and a blessing too. Where are you wrestling right now? What blessing are you holding out for?

What does it mean that "God is with you wherever you go"? Today, take the promise of Genesis 28:15 into the specifics of your week, your work, your home, your hardest relationships, the places where you feel most alone. God is with you in each. What would change if you really believed this?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he meets people who have nothing to commend them, and tell him where you need him to meet you.

Ask him to wrestle with you where he must, not to destroy you but to bless you.

Rest this Sabbath in Christ, the true ladder between heaven and earth.

DAY 50 · WEEK 8

Genesis 36:1-37:36

Esau's line; Joseph sold into Egypt, the Christ-type

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 77 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 36:1-37:36. The first chapter is Esau's genealogy. The second begins the Joseph narrative, the dreams, the brothers' hatred, the selling into slavery. Read the genealogy briefly and focus your attention on chapter 37.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Before turning to Joseph's story, Genesis pauses to record Esau's descendants, the Edomites. This is the standard biblical pattern: the line of promise narrows by first noting what happens to the other line. Esau gets a chapter. Then attention returns to Jacob's family and to Joseph. The chapter that follows introduces one of the longest sustained narratives in the Bible, the Joseph story, which will run for thirteen chapters to the end of Genesis. Joseph is seventeen years old, his father's favorite, gifted with prophetic dreams, and hated by his brothers. Today's reading ends with him in chains, on his way to Egypt.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Genesis 36 is the Edomite genealogy. Esau becomes a nation in his own right.
2. The chapter is included as a record but signals that Esau is now off the main path of God's redemptive purposes.
3. Genesis 37 opens: "Jacob lived in the land of his father's sojournings." The journey home is complete.
4. Joseph is seventeen, working with his brothers, and bringing bad reports of them to his father.
5. Jacob loves Joseph more than the others and makes him a special robe, a "coat of many colors" or a long-sleeved garment.

6. Joseph has two dreams. In the first, his brothers' sheaves bow to his. In the second, the sun, moon, and eleven stars bow to him.
7. Even Jacob rebukes Joseph for the second dream, but "kept the saying in mind" (verse 11).
8. The brothers see Joseph approaching at Dothan and plot to kill him. Reuben tries to save him; Judah suggests selling him instead.
9. Joseph is sold to Ishmaelite traders for twenty shekels of silver. He is taken to Egypt.
10. The brothers dip his coat in goat's blood and deceive Jacob, who "tore his garments and put sackcloth on his loins."

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 37 begins one of the most extended narratives in the Bible. The Joseph story will run thirteen chapters and dominate the rest of Genesis. It is a story of providence, suffering, betrayal, and reversal. And it begins with one of the most dysfunctional family scenes in the Old Testament.

Joseph is seventeen. He is Rachel's son, Jacob's favorite wife's firstborn, and so Jacob favors him. Jacob makes him a special robe, marking him out as the heir apparent. This favoritism is the same fault Jacob's own parents had, and the consequences are predictable. The brothers hate Joseph. They cannot speak peaceably to him.

Joseph does not help. He tells his brothers about his dreams, dreams in which they bow down to him. He brings their father bad reports about them. He is, by any honest reading, an entitled and immature young man. The text does not glorify Joseph in his teenage years. He is being prepared by God for greatness, but he is not yet great.

The plot to kill Joseph is chilling. The brothers see him approaching at Dothan, sent by his father to check on them, and they say, "Here comes this dreamer." They decide to kill him and throw him into a pit. Reuben, the oldest, tries to save Joseph by suggesting they not shed blood but throw him into a pit alive (intending to rescue him later). Then Judah, recognizing they could profit from selling Joseph, suggests they sell him to Ishmaelite traders. Joseph is sold for twenty shekels of silver.

This is the Old Testament's first sale of a person for money. The price, twenty shekels, is the value of a young male slave in the ancient Near East. The deal is done quickly, and Joseph is on his way to Egypt before the brothers have even finished celebrating.

They then deceive Jacob with Joseph's bloodied robe. The deceiver is deceived again. The same Jacob who fooled Isaac with goat skins and savory food is now fooled by his sons with goat's blood and Joseph's coat. The Hebrew is striking: "Identify, please", the same words Jacob's brothers say to him are the words Tamar will later say to Judah in chapter 38. The patterns of deception keep circling back.

Jacob's grief is total. He tears his clothes, puts on sackcloth, and refuses to be comforted. "I shall go down to Sheol to my son, mourning." The favorite son is gone. The light of Jacob's life has been extinguished. He has no idea that Joseph is alive, much less that Joseph will one day save the whole family.

But notice the last sentence of the chapter. "Meanwhile the Midianites had sold him in Egypt to Potiphar, an officer of Pharaoh, the captain of the guard." Joseph is in Egypt. The story is not over. What looks from the ground like total loss is, from heaven's perspective, the careful providential placement of a Hebrew son in the household of an Egyptian official. The God who promised Abraham four hundred years in Egypt is moving the pieces.

STEP 5

Connection

Joseph's descent into Egypt is the beginning of the fulfillment of God's prophecy to Abram in Genesis 15:13, "your offspring will be sojourners in a land that is not theirs and will be servants there." The four hundred years of Egyptian sojourning that culminates in the Exodus begins right here, with one teenage boy in chains on his way south.

STEP 6

Application

The worst day of Joseph's life, being sold into slavery by his own brothers, was the start of God's plan to save his family. This is sobering and hopeful. The events that seem most catastrophic in your life may be the very means by which God is positioning you for what he intends to do. You may not see it. Joseph certainly did not see it as the chains were clinking. But God's hand is in things you cannot trace.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God about a hardship, betrayal, or loss that you cannot yet make sense of.

Ask him to help you trust that he is at work even when you cannot see it.

Ask for eyes to see later what he was doing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 8

"The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed."

GENESIS 39:23

DAY 51 · WEEK 8

Genesis 38:1-39:23

Judah and Tamar; Joseph in Potiphar's house

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 38:1-39:23. Chapter 38 is the strange and difficult Judah-Tamar story, a pause in the Joseph narrative. Chapter 39 returns to Joseph in Potiphar's house. The two chapters together show the contrasting characters of two of Jacob's sons.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Joseph narrative pauses for a chapter to tell the story of Judah, the brother who suggested selling Joseph. Judah leaves the family, marries a Canaanite woman, has three sons, and then, through a strange series of events, finds himself confronted by his daughter-in-law Tamar with his own moral failure. The chapter is uncomfortable but theologically crucial. After Judah, attention returns to Joseph in Egypt, where his integrity in Potiphar's house leads first to promotion and then to imprisonment on false charges.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Judah leaves his family and marries a Canaanite, exactly what Abraham forbade Isaac from doing.
2. His first two sons, Er and Onan, both die under God's judgment for wickedness.
3. Judah sends Tamar back to her father's house, promising her his third son when he is older, a promise he breaks.
4. Tamar, denied her right, disguises herself as a prostitute and sleeps with Judah, who pledges his signet, cord, and staff.
5. When Tamar is found pregnant, Judah orders her burned, until she produces his signet, cord, and staff.

6. Judah's confession is honest: "She is more righteous than I." He acknowledges his sin.
7. Tamar bears twins. Perez (whose name appears in the genealogy of Christ) is born first.
8. Chapter 39: Joseph is now in Potiphar's house. The LORD is with him, and "all that he did, the LORD made it succeed."
9. Potiphar's wife repeatedly tries to seduce Joseph. He refuses, fleeing one day and leaving his garment behind.
10. She falsely accuses Joseph, and he is thrown into prison. Even there, "the LORD was with Joseph and showed him steadfast love."

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 38 and 39 are a study in contrasts. Judah, the brother who proposed selling Joseph, drifts away from the family, marries a Canaanite, and falls into serious moral failure. Joseph, the brother sold into slavery, lives in moral integrity in a foreign land. Both stories are essential to what comes next.

The Judah-Tamar story is strange and uncomfortable, but it is in the Bible for important reasons. First, it shows Judah's character at his worst. He treats Tamar as disposable, breaking his promise to give her his third son. He treats her again as disposable when he sleeps with what he thinks is a prostitute. And he is ready to have her burned to death when her pregnancy is discovered, until he learns the child is his. The chapter is devastating in its portrait of Judah's hypocrisy and double standard.

But it is also redemptive. When confronted with the evidence, Judah confesses: "She is more righteous than I." This is the first time in Genesis we see Judah taking honest moral responsibility. It is the seed of his eventual transformation. The Judah who emerges from chapter 38 chastened will be a different man than the Judah who proposed selling Joseph. And by chapter 44, he will be the one who offers himself in Benjamin's place, a foreshadowing of Christ himself.

The chapter is also significant because Perez, Tamar's son, becomes an ancestor of David and of Christ. The Messiah's lineage runs through this messy story, through a daughter-in-law disguised as a prostitute, through a patriarch caught in his hypocrisy. Matthew 1:3 names them: "Judah the father of Perez and Zerah by Tamar." Even the scandalous becomes part of God's redemptive plan.

Then Genesis 39 returns to Joseph. He is now a slave in the house of Potiphar, captain of Pharaoh's guard. And the text immediately strikes its theme: "The LORD was with Joseph, and he became a successful man." The phrase "the LORD was with Joseph" appears multiple

times in the chapter. It is the key to everything. Joseph is in a foreign land, far from his family, working for a pagan master, and the LORD is with him. The covenant God of his fathers does not stay in Canaan. He travels with his people into exile.

Potiphar quickly recognizes Joseph's competence and gives him oversight of the entire household. Joseph rises from slave to chief of staff. Then comes the test. Potiphar's wife, Joseph's master's wife, repeatedly tries to seduce him. Joseph refuses, day after day. His refusal includes a profound theological statement: "How then can I do this great wickedness and sin against God?" Joseph does not just say he would be wronging Potiphar. He says he would be sinning against God. All sin is ultimately against God, regardless of the human parties involved.

One day Potiphar's wife grabs his garment. Joseph flees, leaving the garment behind. She uses it as false evidence and accuses him of attempted rape. Potiphar throws him in prison. Joseph has done everything right, and the result is worse than before. Demoted from rising star to prisoner. But the chapter closes with the same theme: "The LORD was with Joseph and showed him steadfast love and gave him favor in the sight of the keeper of the prison." Wherever Joseph is, slave, manager, prisoner, the LORD is with him.

STEP 5

Connection

Judah's confession (Genesis 38) and Joseph's integrity (Genesis 39) both serve the larger story. Judah is being prepared for transformation; Joseph is being prepared for elevation. And critically, both are being prepared to be ancestors in the line of Christ. Judah's son Perez will be in Matthew 1. Joseph will save the family that brings forth the Messiah.

STEP 6

Application

Two contrasts to take with you. First, Judah teaches us about the deceptive drift of mixing with the world. He left the covenant family, married outside it, treated others as disposable. The drift was slow but devastating. Examine your own life. Where are you drifting? Second, Joseph teaches us about integrity in exile. Far from family, far from familiar worship, in a culture hostile to his values, Joseph refused to compromise. He said no to a powerful woman's advances, even when no one would have known. The LORD was with him in his integrity. The LORD is with you in yours.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess where you have drifted, as Judah did, or been tempted, as Joseph was.

Ask him for strength to flee sin when no one would know.

Thank him that he is with you in any place where you feel far from home or unfairly treated.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 8

"The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed."

GENESIS 39:23

DAY 52 · WEEK 8

Psalm 37:1-22

Do not fret; trust in the LORD, providence over the wicked

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 37:1-22 slowly, twice. This is a wisdom psalm, a long meditation on the apparent prosperity of the wicked and the patient confidence of the righteous. It is the perfect psalm for those who have been reading about Joseph's unjust suffering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 37 is one of the great wisdom psalms, long, calm, deliberate. It addresses the question that has haunted believers in every generation: why do the wicked seem to prosper while the righteous suffer? David's answer is patience and trust. Do not fret. Do not envy. The wicked will fade like grass; the righteous will inherit the land. The psalm fits Joseph's situation exactly, he has just been imprisoned for refusing to sin, while the wicked seem to triumph.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with three commands: "Fret not... be not envious... Trust in the LORD."
2. The wicked are compared to grass that quickly fades.
3. Verse 4: "Delight yourself in the LORD, and he will give you the desires of your heart."
4. Verse 5: "Commit your way to the LORD; trust in him." The verb "commit" literally means "roll", roll your way onto him.
5. Verse 7: "Be still before the LORD and wait patiently for him." Stillness and waiting are part of righteousness.
6. Verse 11 anticipates Jesus' Beatitude: "The meek shall inherit the land."
7. The contrast continues: the wicked plot and gnash their teeth, but the LORD laughs because he sees their day coming.

8 Verse 18: “The LORD knows the days of the blameless, and their heritage will remain forever.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 37 is one of the wisest psalms in the Psalter. It does not deny that the wicked prosper. It does not pretend life is fair. It accepts the painful reality and then offers the corrective: a long view. The wicked seem to flourish for a moment; the righteous inherit forever.

Three commands open the psalm. Fret not. Envy not. Trust. These are the daily disciplines of the believer facing apparent injustice. Fretting is the spiritual equivalent of constantly checking a wound. Envying the wicked is letting their apparent success poison your contentment. Trust is the alternative, letting God hold what you cannot control.

The reason for not fretting is the long view: the wicked are like grass. They look prosperous in the morning. By evening, they wither. Compared with eternity, the success of the wicked is brief. The temptation is to compare time spans incorrectly, to weigh ten years of someone’s worldly success against eternity and conclude that they are winning. But the comparison is wrong. They will fade. The righteous endure.

Verse 4 is one of the most quoted in the Psalter: “Delight yourself in the LORD, and he will give you the desires of your heart.” This is sometimes misread as a transaction, delight in God and you will get what you want. But the deeper meaning is transformative: delight in the LORD, and your desires themselves will be reshaped. What you want will become what he wants. The desires of your heart, properly aligned with God, will indeed be granted, because they will be the right desires.

The image of “rolling your way onto the LORD” in verse 5 is wonderful. You roll your burden onto someone else, and you are free of it. The Christian life involves daily rolling, daily handing over to God what you cannot carry yourself.

Verse 11 anticipates Jesus’ Beatitude: “The meek shall inherit the land.” Jesus quoted this exact verse in Matthew 5:5. The meek, those who do not assert their rights, who do not fret about injustice, who do not envy the wicked, they get the inheritance in the end. The world thinks meekness is weakness. The Bible says meekness is the strongest posture, because it trusts the One who holds the future.

And the psalm gives us a striking image of God: “The LORD laughs at the wicked, for he sees that his day is coming.” God is not anxious about injustice. He laughs. Not in cruelty, but in confidence. He knows the end. He knows when the wicked will fall. He knows when his people will be vindicated. We can rest in that knowledge.

STEP 5

Connection

Joseph has just been thrown into prison for refusing to sin. His brothers, who sold him into slavery, are eating well at home. Potiphar's wife, who lied about him, sleeps in her bed. Joseph sleeps in chains. Psalm 37 is the song Joseph could have prayed. Do not fret. Trust the LORD. The wicked are like grass. The meek inherit. This is the wisdom that sustained Joseph in his unjust suffering, and it is the wisdom that sustains believers still.

STEP 6

Application

Today, examine where you are fretting. What injustice in your life are you turning over and over? What success of someone else are you watching with envy? Bring it before God. Then practice the three commands: Fret not. Envy not. Trust. And practice the discipline of verse 4, delight yourself in the LORD. Not as a strategy to get what you want, but as a means of becoming someone whose wants are right.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what makes you fret or envy, and lay it before him.
- Ask him to reshape your desires by delight in him.
- Pray for patience to wait for him and not for your own way.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 8

"The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed."

GENESIS 39:23

DAY 53 · WEEK 8

Psalm 37:23-40

The steps of a man are established by the LORD

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 37:23-40 slowly, twice. This is the second half of the great wisdom psalm. The themes continue: the patient confidence of the righteous, the certain end of the wicked. As you read, listen for the personal note David sounds, his own life experience speaking.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second half of Psalm 37 continues the meditation on the long view. The psalmist now adds his personal testimony: "I have been young, and now am old, yet I have not seen the righteous forsaken." David has lived through enough to know how God's economy works. The patient eventually receive. The wicked eventually fall. The promise of the meek inheriting the land continues to anchor the psalm.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 23: "The steps of a man are established by the LORD, when he delights in his way." God orders the path of his people.
2. Verse 24: "Though he fall, he shall not be cast headlong, for the LORD upholds his hand." Falls happen, but recovery follows.
3. Verse 25 is David's personal testimony: "I have been young, and now am old, yet I have not seen the righteous forsaken."
4. Verses 27-29: Turn from evil, do good, dwell forever. The righteous have the long inheritance.
5. Verses 30-31 describe the speech and heart of the righteous: "the law of his God is in his heart; his steps do not slip."

6. Verse 34: “Wait for the LORD and keep his way, and he will exalt you to inherit the land.”
7. Verses 35-36: The wicked man flourished like a green tree, but when the psalmist looked again, he was gone.
8. Verses 37-38: “Mark the blameless… for there is a future for the man of peace.”
9. The psalm closes: “The salvation of the righteous is from the LORD; he is their stronghold in the time of trouble.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

The second half of Psalm 37 deepens what the first half established. Trust the LORD. Wait for him. The wicked will pass; the righteous will inherit. But now David adds personal witness. He has lived a long life. He has seen things. And what he has seen confirms what the psalm has been saying.

Verse 23 is profound. “The steps of a man are established by the LORD, when he delights in his way.” For the believer who delights in God’s way, every step is established. Not random. Not accidental. Even the falls that happen are caught by the LORD’s hand. Verse 24: “though he fall, he shall not be cast headlong.” This is one of the great pastoral truths of the psalm. Christians fall. We sin. We make mistakes. We stumble. But we are not cast headlong, because the LORD upholds our hand. The fall does not become a free fall, because the same LORD who established our steps catches us when we stumble.

Verse 25 is David’s testimony. “I have been young, and now am old, yet I have not seen the righteous forsaken or his children begging for bread.” This is not a promise of material prosperity, believers do face poverty in this fallen world. But it is a testimony about God’s faithfulness across a lifetime. David has watched. He has paid attention. The righteous get cared for, sometimes in ways that seem miraculous, but always somehow. God does not forsake those who fear him.

The image of the wicked in verses 35-36 is striking. “I have seen a wicked, ruthless man, spreading himself like a green laurel tree. But he passed away, and behold, he was no more; though I sought him, he could not be found.” David is describing what he has watched happen. The villain who seemed unstoppable simply…disappeared. There came a day when his glory was gone, and even the search for his memory turned up nothing. Time is on the side of the righteous.

The psalm closes with a beautiful summary. “The salvation of the righteous is from the LORD; he is their stronghold in the time of trouble. The LORD helps them and delivers them; he delivers them from the wicked and saves them, because they take refuge in him.” This is

the architecture of Christian confidence. Not our righteousness, but his salvation. Not our strength, but his stronghold. Not our deliverance, but his hand. We take refuge in him. He does the saving.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 37 is the wisdom psalm that fits Joseph's situation, fits David's situation, and fits the believer's situation in every age. Yesterday Joseph was thrown into prison for refusing to sin. Today, Psalm 37 reminds us that the righteous are not forsaken. The LORD establishes our steps. We will yet be vindicated.

STEP 6

Application

Today, mark the blameless. Verse 37 says, "Mark the blameless and behold the upright, for there is a future for the man of peace." Take some time today to think about someone you know who has lived a quiet life of faithfulness. Maybe a parent or grandparent. Maybe a pastor or teacher. Maybe a friend who has walked with God through real hardship. Mark them. Tell them what you have seen. And ask God to make you one of those who, in old age, can say: I have been young, and now am old, and I have not seen the righteous forsaken.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to order your steps today, one by one.

Thank him that when you fall he upholds your hand.

Ask him for a long faithfulness that becomes its own testimony.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 8

"The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed."

GENESIS 39:23

DAY 54 · WEEK 8

Genesis 40:1-41:57

The cupbearer and baker; Pharaoh's dreams; Joseph exalted

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 77 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 40:1-41:57. Joseph in prison interprets dreams for two of Pharaoh's officials. Two years later, Pharaoh has dreams of his own, and Joseph is finally remembered. The seventeen-year-old slave is now a thirty-year-old vizier of Egypt.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Joseph has been in prison for some time. Two of Pharaoh's officials, the chief cupbearer and the chief baker, are imprisoned with him, and each has a strange dream. Joseph interprets both. The cupbearer is restored to his position; the baker is executed. Joseph asks the cupbearer to remember him, but he forgets, for two years. Then Pharaoh has dreams that none of his wise men can interpret, and the cupbearer finally remembers Joseph. Joseph stands before Pharaoh, interprets the dreams, and is elevated to second in command over all of Egypt.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Joseph's first words about dream interpretation: "Do not interpretations belong to God? Please tell them to me" (40:8).
2. Joseph correctly interprets both dreams, but the cupbearer forgets him.
3. Two years pass before Pharaoh's dream. Joseph is in his early thirties when he finally stands before Pharaoh.
4. Pharaoh's dreams: seven fat cows eaten by seven gaunt cows; seven good ears of grain eaten by seven blighted ears.
5. Joseph attributes everything to God: "It is not in me; God will give Pharaoh a favorable answer" (41:16).

6. He interprets the dream, seven years of plenty followed by seven years of famine, and recommends a plan.
7. Pharaoh promotes Joseph: "Can we find a man like this, in whom is the Spirit of God?"
8. Joseph receives Pharaoh's signet ring, fine linen, a gold chain, and the second chariot. He is renamed Zaphenath-Paneah.
9. Joseph marries Asenath. They have two sons: Manasseh ("God has made me forget all my hardship") and Ephraim ("God has made me fruitful in the land of my affliction").
10. The seven years of plenty come and go; the famine arrives; people from every land come to Egypt to buy grain.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 40 and 41 are the turning point in Joseph's story and the moment when the long providence of God becomes visible. For thirteen years, Joseph has been moving steadily downward, from favored son, to slave, to favored servant, to wrongly accused, to forgotten prisoner. In a single day, he ascends from prison to the second highest position in the empire.

The chapters teach us something essential about God's timing. The cupbearer could have remembered Joseph immediately, and Joseph might have been freed. But God's plan required Joseph in prison for two more years. Why? Because Pharaoh did not yet need a dream interpreter. The famine had not yet come. The whole reason God positioned Joseph in Pharaoh's court was so that he could be there to manage the seven years of plenty and the seven years of famine. If Joseph had been released too early, he would have been just another freed slave. God's timing requires the suffering.

Joseph's interpretive principle is striking. "Do not interpretations belong to God?" he says in chapter 40. And to Pharaoh in chapter 41: "It is not in me; God will give Pharaoh a favorable answer." Joseph has spent thirteen years in adversity. He has every reason to be bitter, to claim credit, to assert himself. Instead, he points to God at every turn. Notice that he is doing this before a pagan king who could grant him freedom or send him back to prison. Joseph is not editing his theology for a different audience. He says the same thing to Pharaoh that he said to the cupbearer in prison.

Pharaoh's response is remarkable. "Can we find a man like this, in whom is the Spirit of God?" An Egyptian king recognizes the Spirit of God in a Hebrew slave. The same Spirit who will fill the prophets and ultimately fill Christ is at work in Joseph, and even Pharaoh can see it. The text is making a point: when God is genuinely with someone, even unbelievers can recognize it.

Joseph's elevation is total. He receives Pharaoh's signet ring (delegated authority), fine linen and a gold chain (royal insignia), and the second chariot (proximity to power). He is renamed, a sign of his new identity. He marries an Egyptian woman, Asenath. He has two sons whose names carry deep theological meaning. Manasseh, "God has made me forget all my hardship." Joseph is naming his first son after the way God has worked in him. The bitter years are not erased, but they are now bearable. Ephraim, "God has made me fruitful in the land of my affliction." Joseph is acknowledging that the place of his suffering became the place of his blessing. Egypt was the place of his slavery, his false accusation, his forgotten years. Now Egypt is the place of his fruitfulness. The land of affliction has become the soil of his calling.

Then the seven years of plenty come and go, and the famine arrives. The text says people from "all the earth" came to Egypt to buy grain. The stage is being set for the family of Jacob to make the journey south. Joseph is in place. The famine is the means. God is preparing to bring his promise, that Israel would sojourn in a land that was not theirs, into history.

STEP 5

Connection

Joseph's elevation is one of the great divine reversals in the Old Testament. Sold for twenty shekels of silver, he becomes the second most powerful man in Egypt. The reversal points forward to Christ, who, sold for thirty pieces of silver, became the King of kings. And the seven years of famine that will draw Joseph's family to Egypt is the beginning of the four hundred years of sojourning that God predicted to Abram in Genesis 15.

STEP 6

Application

Two truths to take with you. First, your timing is not God's timing. The two years Joseph waited in prison felt unnecessary to him; they were essential to what God was doing. The waiting season you are in may feel pointless. It is not. God is using the time. Second, the place of your affliction may become the place of your fruitfulness. Egypt was Joseph's land of suffering before it became the land of his calling. Whatever hard season you are in, physical, emotional, vocational, relational, God can make it the soil of unexpected fruit. Pray today that he will make you, like Joseph, fruitful in the land of your affliction.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God about a season of waiting that feels pointless, and ask him to use it.

Ask him to make you fruitful where you are afflicted.

Ask for grace to give him credit in your conversations and work.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 8

"The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed."

GENESIS 39:23

DAY 55 · WEEK 8

Genesis 42:1-43:34

Brothers in Egypt; Benjamin brought; Joseph's emotion

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 42:1-43:34. The famine has reached Canaan. Jacob sends his sons to Egypt to buy grain. They stand before Joseph without recognizing him. Joseph plays a long, careful game, testing his brothers, seeing if they have changed.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The famine in Canaan grows severe. Jacob is forced to send ten of his sons, all but Benjamin, the youngest, down to Egypt to buy grain. They stand before the Egyptian vizier without recognizing him, but he recognizes them. Joseph could reveal himself immediately. He does not. Instead, he engineers a careful series of tests to discover whether his brothers have changed. He accuses them of being spies. He demands they bring Benjamin. He keeps Simeon as a hostage. He plants their money back in their sacks. The brothers return home in fear. Then, when the food runs out, they must return, this time with Benjamin.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 42:6, Joseph's brothers bow down before him, fulfilling his dreams from twenty years earlier.
2. Joseph recognizes them but pretends not to. He speaks to them through an interpreter.
3. He accuses them of being spies, threatens them, and tests them. He is harsh on the surface, weeping privately.
4. He keeps Simeon as a hostage and sends the rest home to bring Benjamin.
5. On the journey home, they discover their money returned in their sacks. Their consciences begin to stir: "What is this that God has done to us?"

6. When they reach Jacob, he refuses to send Benjamin. “You would bring down my gray hairs with sorrow to Sheol.”
7. The famine grows worse. Eventually, Judah persuades Jacob: “I will be a pledge of his safety. From my hand you shall require him.”
8. The brothers return with double money and gifts. Joseph receives them, sees Benjamin, and is overcome.
9. Joseph hosts a feast for them. Benjamin’s portion is five times the others, a deliberate test of jealousy. The brothers pass.

STEP 4

Interpretation

These two chapters are an emotional crescendo. Joseph, twenty years after being sold into slavery, finally faces his brothers. He could destroy them. He has the power. They are at his mercy. But Joseph is not interested in revenge. He wants to know if they have changed.

The testing is masterful. Joseph speaks roughly. He accuses them of being spies. He demands they bring their youngest brother. He keeps one as hostage. He plants their money back in their sacks. Every move is designed to put them in a tight place where their true character will surface. And the brothers begin to crack. As soon as the trouble starts, they whisper among themselves: “In truth we are guilty concerning our brother, in that we saw the distress of his soul, when he begged us and we did not listen. That is why this distress has come upon us.” Twenty years of buried guilt rises up. They have not forgotten Joseph. They have just been carrying him as a hidden weight.

Joseph hears them. The text says: “They did not know that Joseph understood them, for there was an interpreter between them. Then he turned away from them and wept.” This is one of the most moving scenes in Genesis. Joseph hears the confession he has been waiting twenty years to hear, and he weeps. Not because they are suffering. Because they are owning what they did. The transformation has begun.

The journey home and the painful conversation with Jacob is excruciating. Jacob cannot bear to lose another son of Rachel. Benjamin is all he has left of his beloved wife. He refuses to send him. The famine forces the issue, but it is Judah who finally breaks through. “I will be a pledge of his safety. From my hand you shall require him. If I do not bring him back to you and set him before you, then let me bear the blame forever.”

This is a transformation. Judah is the brother who once said, “Let us sell him to the Ishmaelites.” Now he is offering himself as security for the youngest. The man who proposed selling Joseph is now pledging his own freedom for Benjamin. This is exactly what Joseph has been testing for. Has Judah changed? The answer is yes.

When they return to Egypt with Benjamin, Joseph cannot keep his composure. He sees his brother, his only full brother, for the first time in over twenty years. He has to leave the room to weep. He composes himself, returns, and hosts a banquet. He seats them in birth order, to their astonishment. He gives Benjamin five times the portion of the others, a deliberate test. Twenty years ago, special favor for the youngest son led to murderous jealousy. How will they react now?

They eat and drink with him. There is no jealousy. The brothers have changed.

STEP 5

Connection

Joseph's dreams from Genesis 37 are now being fulfilled in real time, his brothers bowing before him. But the deeper purpose is the transformation of the brothers themselves. The man who once proposed selling Joseph is now offering himself for Benjamin. This is the seed of Judah becoming the kingly tribe, the tribe from which David and ultimately Christ will come.

STEP 6

Application

Sometimes love requires the long test. Joseph could have revealed himself immediately. He could have showered his brothers with gifts and forgiveness on day one. He did not. He took them through a process. The process was not cruelty, it was love directed at transformation. Sometimes the people we love most need our slowest, most patient confrontation, not our immediate forgiveness. Forgiveness is given. Trust is rebuilt. The two are not the same thing. Today, ask God for wisdom about a relationship where you have been asked to receive someone back. Forgive freely. But do not skip the work of rebuilding trust.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God for the wisdom to forgive freely and to rebuild trust slowly where it has been broken.

Tell him about someone you long to see reconciled, and pray for them.

Ask him to give you a heart like Joseph's, full of love and ready for tears.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 8

“The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed.”

GENESIS 39:23

DAY 56 · WEEK 8

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. The week you have completed followed Joseph from his lowest point, sold into slavery, falsely accused, forgotten in prison, to his elevation as second over Egypt. Take time today to consider how God was with Joseph at every stage of his descent.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed."

GENESIS 39:23

REST

Meditation

Genesis 39:23 is the refrain of the Joseph story. The phrase "The LORD was with Joseph" appears multiple times, when he is sold as a slave, when he is in Potiphar's house, when he is in prison, when he stands before Pharaoh. Wherever he is, the LORD is with him.

This is the gospel's promise restated. Joseph's circumstances ranged from privileged son to abused slave to wrongly accused prisoner to ruler of Egypt. In every condition, the LORD was with him. The presence of God was not contingent on Joseph's success. It was the source of his eventual success, but it was equally present in his lowest moments.

Say the verse to yourself, particularly the second half, "whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed." This is not a promise that everything you attempt will work out. It is a promise that God's purposes through you cannot fail. Joseph's "success" included thirteen years of

suffering. The LORD's success and our preferred outcomes are not always the same thing, but they are always good, and they are always sure.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

The week began with Esau's genealogy and then plunged into the Joseph story, the dreams, the brothers' hatred, the selling into slavery. You read the strange Judah-Tamar story alongside Joseph's integrity in Potiphar's house. You worshiped through both halves of Psalm 37, learning the wisdom of patience while the wicked seem to prosper. You watched Joseph rise from prison to second in command over all of Egypt. And the week ended with his brothers standing before him without recognizing him, bowing down, just as Joseph's childhood dreams had foretold.

The week is about hidden providence. Joseph could not see what God was doing. The brothers could not see what God was undoing. But the LORD was with Joseph at every step, through betrayal, false accusation, forgotten years in prison, and the same LORD was preparing the moment of reversal.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where in your life right now does it feel like the LORD is not "making it succeed"? Joseph's experience suggests that God's presence is not always evident through circumstances. The thirteen years between Joseph's sale and his elevation included times when even he must have wondered if God had forgotten him. What season are you in? How does Joseph's story help you wait?

How does Joseph point you to Christ? Joseph was the beloved son, sold for silver, falsely accused, imprisoned with criminals, elevated to a throne, and used by God to save the very brothers who had betrayed him. Every detail prefigures Jesus. Where do you see Christ most clearly in the Joseph story? And how does seeing Joseph's reversal deepen your hope in Christ's resurrection?

Where do you need to choose integrity in your own "Potiphar's house"? Joseph said no to a powerful person's advances when no one would have known. He chose the harder right over the easier wrong. Is there a place in your life today where integrity will cost you something? What would it look like to choose it anyway, trusting that the LORD is with you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for being with Joseph in the pit, in prison, and on the throne, and for being with you in every season.

Ask him to make you a person of integrity in the place you are right now.

Rest in his presence this Sabbath, in success and in failure.

DAY 57 · WEEK 9

Genesis 44:1-45:28

Judah's plea; Joseph revealed, grace to those who betrayed

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 55 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 44:1-45:28. The climax of the Joseph narrative. Joseph stages one final test, Benjamin will be arrested for theft. Judah's response is one of the great speeches in the Old Testament. And then Joseph reveals himself, and the long, agonizing reunion finally happens.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Joseph has tested his brothers thoroughly. He has one final test to administer. He plants his silver cup in Benjamin's sack and sends them home. His steward overtakes them, accuses them of theft, and announces that Benjamin must remain in Egypt as a slave. This is the moment of truth. Will the brothers abandon Benjamin as they abandoned Joseph twenty years ago? Or has something changed in them? Judah's response is one of the most moving speeches in the Bible. And after hearing it, Joseph can no longer hold back.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Joseph plants his silver cup in Benjamin's sack, a final test of how the brothers will respond when Benjamin is in trouble.
2. When the steward catches up to them, all the brothers tear their clothes (a sign of deep grief) and return together.
3. Judah steps forward. His speech (44:18-34) is one of the longest individual speeches in Genesis.
4. Judah recounts the family history honestly. He emphasizes how Jacob loves Benjamin and how his loss would kill the old man.

5. Verse 33: Judah offers himself in Benjamin's place. "Let your servant remain instead of the boy as a servant to my lord, and let the boy go back with his brothers."
6. Joseph cannot hold back. He sends all the Egyptians out of the room and weeps so loudly that the Egyptians outside hear him.
7. His self-revelation: "I am Joseph! Is my father still alive?" The brothers are speechless with dread.
8. Verse 5: "Do not be distressed or angry with yourselves... for God sent me before you to preserve life."
9. Joseph repeats the theme: "It was not you who sent me here, but God" (verse 8).
10. He tells them to bring Jacob and the whole family to Egypt, they will live in Goshen, near him.
11. The chapter ends with Jacob hearing the news and refusing to believe it, then finally believing: "It is enough; Joseph my son is still alive."

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 44 and 45 are the moral and theological climax of the Joseph story. Everything has been building toward Judah's speech and Joseph's revelation. After this, the rest of Genesis is denouement.

The final test is engineered with perfect insight. Joseph plants his cup in Benjamin's sack. When the brothers are caught, they have a choice. They could blame Benjamin, leave him behind, and walk away. After all, only Benjamin is accused. The rest of them are free to go. This is exactly what they did to Joseph twenty years ago. They handed him over and walked away. The cup test is asking: will they do it again?

Their response is the first proof. Verse 13: "They tore their clothes." All of them. Together. This is communal grief. They cannot bear to lose another brother. They return to the city together, not separately.

Then Judah steps forward. His speech is one of the longest sustained speeches in Genesis, and it is masterful. He recounts the family history honestly. He explains how Jacob has already lost one son (Joseph, presumed dead), and how losing Benjamin would kill the old man. The speech is full of his father's words, Judah quotes Jacob repeatedly, as if he has been listening, as if he finally understands what Benjamin means to his father.

And then comes the moment. Verse 33: "Now therefore, please let your servant remain instead of the boy as a servant to my lord, and let the boy go back with his brothers." Judah offers himself. The brother who once said, "Let us sell him to the Ishmaelites," is now offering to be the slave instead. Twenty years ago, Judah benefited from selling a brother. Now Judah is willing to suffer to save a brother. This is what transformation looks like. The kingly tribe is being formed in this moment. The tribe of David, the tribe of Christ, formed by a Judah who finally learns to lay down his life for his brother.

Joseph cannot hold back. He has been keeping up the appearance of harsh Egyptian official for chapters now, weeping in secret rooms. He cannot any longer. He sends all the Egyptians out, this revelation is family business, and he weeps so loudly that the Egyptians outside the room hear him. And then the words: "I am Joseph. Is my father still alive?"

The brothers are paralyzed with terror. The man they sold has become the man with power over their lives. He could have them all killed in an instant. But Joseph's next words are the heart of the gospel of Genesis. "Do not be distressed or angry with yourselves because you sold me here, for God sent me before you to preserve life." Notice the theology. Their sin was real. God's purpose was real. Both are true. Joseph does not minimize what they did. He acknowledges it. But he sees that, behind their sin, God was working, moving the pieces, positioning Joseph in Egypt, so that when the famine came, life could be preserved. The same event was both wickedness (on the brothers' part) and providence (on God's part). Acts 4:28 will say exactly the same thing about the crucifixion of Christ.

Joseph repeats the point three times in this short speech. "God sent me before you to preserve life." "It was not you who sent me here, but God." "He has made me a father to Pharaoh and lord of all his house." This is not naive optimism. This is hard-won theology. Joseph has spent thirteen years in slavery and prison. He has every right to be bitter. He chooses instead to see the hand of God. And by choosing that, he releases his brothers from their guilt and saves the family.

STEP 5

Connection

Judah's offer of himself for Benjamin is the moment that transforms the kingly tribe. From this man and this moment will come David, and from David will come Christ, the true substitute who takes the place of his brothers. And Joseph's interpretation of his suffering, "You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good" (which will be stated explicitly in chapter 50), anticipates Romans 8:28: "all things work together for good for those who love God."

STEP 6

Application

Look at your story with Joseph's eyes. The wrongs done to you were real. The sin against you was real. But behind every betrayal, every loss, every closed door, God was working, moving the pieces, positioning you for what came next. This is not denial of pain. Joseph wept. But it is faith in providence. Today, name one painful chapter of your life that, in retrospect, you can begin to see God's hand in. Thank him for it. And ask him to give you Joseph's eyes for the chapters you cannot yet read.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Name a wound that was real, and tell God about it without softening it.
- Ask him to give you Joseph's eyes to see how he has used it, or may yet use it.
- Ask him for a heart willing to lay down its life for others, like Judah's.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 9

"You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive."

GENESIS 50:20

DAY 58 · WEEK 9

Genesis 46:1-47:31

Jacob to Egypt; Israel settled in Goshen

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 46:1-47:31. Jacob and the whole family, seventy people, make the long journey down to Egypt. They are settled in Goshen. Jacob meets Pharaoh. The years pass, and Jacob prepares for his death.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The famine continues. Jacob, now an old man, packs up the entire family and heads to Egypt. On the way, God appears to him at Beersheba and confirms the move: “Do not be afraid to go down to Egypt, for there I will make you into a great nation.” Joseph rides out to meet his father after twenty-two years. The family is settled in the region of Goshen, the best of the land. Jacob is presented to Pharaoh. The years pass. Jacob, near death, makes Joseph swear to bury him in Canaan, not Egypt.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Jacob stops to offer sacrifices at Beersheba. He is honoring the place where his father Isaac had also encountered God.
2. God speaks to Jacob in night visions, calling him “Jacob, Jacob”, affectionate repetition.
3. Verse 46:3: “Do not be afraid to go down to Egypt, for there I will make you into a great nation.” This fulfills Genesis 15:13.
4. The list of seventy persons (46:8-27) is the foundation of Israel. Seventy is a number of completeness.
5. Joseph rides up in his chariot to meet Jacob. They weep together. Twenty-two years of separation.

6. Jacob is presented to Pharaoh. He blesses Pharaoh, the lesser blessing the greater? Or the patriarch blessing the king?
7. Jacob's life, "few and evil have been the days of the years of my life", is candidly described as hard.
8. The famine grows severe. The Egyptians sell their flocks, then their land, then themselves to Pharaoh in exchange for food.
9. Israel settles in Goshen, prospers, and multiplies (verse 47:27).
10. Jacob, near death, makes Joseph swear with the same oath Abraham used, to bury him in the cave of Machpelah.

STEP 4

Interpretation

These two chapters cover the final settling of the patriarchal family in Egypt. The descent into Egypt that began with Joseph as a slave now welcomes the whole family as honored guests. The four-hundred-year sojourning that God predicted to Abram in Genesis 15:13 has officially begun.

Notice the careful way the move is framed. Jacob does not just rush off to Egypt. He stops at Beersheba, the place his father Isaac worshiped, and offers sacrifices. He pauses to seek God's blessing on the journey. And God meets him. In a night vision, God speaks: "I am God, the God of your father. Do not be afraid to go down to Egypt, for there I will make you into a great nation. I myself will go down with you to Egypt, and I will also bring you up again." This is one of the most important promises in the patriarchal narratives. God is going down to Egypt with them. The God of Canaan is not bound to Canaan. He travels with his people. And he commits to bring them back. The descent is real, but it is not abandonment.

The list of the seventy who came to Egypt is the foundation of Israel. The biblical writers will refer to this number repeatedly. Seventy elders will accompany Moses to Sinai. Seventy disciples will be sent out by Jesus. The number marks the people of God, small, complete, gathered.

The reunion between Joseph and Jacob is brief but powerful. "Joseph presented himself to him and fell on his neck and wept on his neck a good while. Israel said to Joseph, "Now let me die, since I have seen your face and know that you are still alive."" Twenty-two years of grief and waiting end in a single embrace.

Jacob is presented to Pharaoh. The exchange is striking. Jacob "blesses Pharaoh" both at the beginning and end of the encounter. Hebrews 7:7 says, "It is beyond dispute that the inferior is blessed by the superior." The aged patriarch blessing the king of Egypt is a quiet but

powerful statement of who really represents the God of heaven. Jacob's life is described candidly: "Few and evil have been the days of the years of my life, and they have not attained to the days of the years of the life of my fathers." Jacob has not had an easy life. He acknowledges it. But he stands before Pharaoh as a man of God.

The famine policy section (47:13-26) is one that bothers many modern readers. Joseph collects all the money from Egypt, then all the livestock, then all the land, in exchange for food. By the end, the Egyptians have sold themselves into Pharaoh's service. Joseph is implementing what is essentially a transition from a free society to a centralized monarchy. The text describes this without moral comment. The full implications will become visible only later, when a new pharaoh, one who "did not know Joseph", uses this centralized power to enslave Jacob's descendants.

The chapter ends with Jacob, near death, calling Joseph and making him swear an oath. The patriarchs are passing the covenant. Jacob will not be buried in Egypt. He will be buried in the cave of Machpelah, with Abraham and Sarah, with Isaac and Rebekah, with Leah. The covenant family does not lose its grip on the promised land even in the years of Egyptian residence. They will be sojourners, but their bones will go home.

STEP 5

Connection

The descent into Egypt is the literal fulfillment of Genesis 15:13. God told Abram his offspring would sojourn in a foreign land for four hundred years. The journey down begins here. And God's promise to Jacob, "I will bring you up again", is the seed of the Exodus, the great act of redemption that will define Israel's identity.

STEP 6

Application

Two truths to take with you. First, when God calls you somewhere difficult, he goes with you. He told Jacob, "I myself will go down with you to Egypt." He still goes with his people. Whatever Egypt you find yourself in, a hard season, a difficult place, an unwelcome calling, God does not stay behind. He goes. Second, your story is part of a longer story. The descent into Egypt would have looked like a tragedy to anyone watching. From God's vantage point, it was the means by which a family became a nation. Your present descent may be the means by which God is making something larger than you can yet see.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he goes with you into every hard place.

Ask him to make you willing to leave what is familiar when he calls.

Thank him that he brings his people up again after every descent.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 9

"You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive."

GENESIS 50:20

DAY 59 · WEEK 9

Genesis 48:1-50:26

Jacob's blessings; Judah's primacy; Joseph's death

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 48:1-50:26. The final three chapters of Genesis. Jacob blesses Joseph's sons and then blesses all twelve of his own sons in a prophetic poem. He dies and is buried in Canaan. Joseph forgives his brothers a final time. Genesis ends with his bones in a coffin in Egypt, awaiting the return to the promised land.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

We have come to the end of Genesis. Jacob, near death, calls Joseph to him and blesses Joseph's two sons, Ephraim and Manasseh, crossing his hands so that the younger receives the greater blessing. Then in chapter 49 he summons all twelve sons and prophesies their futures. The blessing on Judah is particularly significant, a scepter will not depart from him until the one to whom it belongs comes. Jacob dies. Joseph and the brothers travel to Canaan to bury him. Joseph reassures the brothers one final time and dies at 110, his bones embalmed and placed in a coffin in Egypt, awaiting the day they will be carried back to the promised land.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Jacob adopts Joseph's two sons, Ephraim and Manasseh, as his own, they become two of the twelve tribes.
2. Jacob crosses his hands, blessing the younger (Ephraim) over the older (Manasseh), the pattern of election repeats.
3. Genesis 49 is the blessing of the twelve sons, one of the most important prophetic poems in the Old Testament.

4. Reuben loses his birthright for defiling his father's bed. Simeon and Levi are cursed for their violence.
5. Judah receives the great blessing: "The scepter shall not depart from Judah… until tribute comes to him; and to him shall be the obedience of the peoples."
6. This is one of the earliest Messianic prophecies, the one to whom the scepter belongs is the coming Christ.
7. Joseph receives a double portion through his two sons. He is called "a fruitful bough by a spring."
8. Jacob dies. The Egyptians mourn him for seventy days, extraordinary honor.
9. Joseph and his brothers carry Jacob's body to Canaan and bury him in the cave of Machpelah.
10. After Jacob's death, the brothers fear retribution. Joseph weeps: "You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good."
11. Joseph dies at 110. His last words: "God will surely visit you, and you shall carry up my bones from here."

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis ends in a way that anticipates everything still to come. Jacob blesses his sons, and the future of the twelve tribes is sketched out in advance. Joseph forgives his brothers in the most theologically loaded sentence in the book. And the patriarchal era closes with Joseph's bones in a coffin, waiting for the Exodus.

Jacob's blessing of Ephraim and Manasseh is the latest example of the pattern that has run throughout Genesis. The younger is preferred over the older. Isaac over Ishmael. Jacob over Esau. Now Ephraim over Manasseh. When Joseph tries to redirect his father's hands to favor the older son, Jacob refuses. "I know, my son, I know." The pattern is not accidental. God's grace consistently overturns natural expectations. He does not save by birth order, by merit, by social standing. He saves by sovereign choice.

Genesis 49 is one of the most important prophetic chapters in the Old Testament. Jacob, dying, calls his sons together and tells them what will happen "in days to come." The text is dense and poetic. Reuben loses his right of firstborn for his earlier sin with Bilhah. Simeon and Levi are cursed for their violent revenge against Shechem, they will be scattered in Israel (which Levi will become, as the priestly tribe scattered among the others, and Simeon, which will eventually be absorbed into Judah).

And then comes the great Judah blessing. "Judah, your brothers shall praise you... The scepter shall not depart from Judah, nor the ruler's staff from between his feet, until tribute comes to him; and to him shall be the obedience of the peoples." This is one of the earliest and clearest Messianic prophecies in the Bible. From Judah will come the line of kings. From Judah will come David. And from the line of David will come the one to whom the scepter ultimately belongs, Jesus Christ, the Lion of the tribe of Judah (Revelation 5:5). The wine and milk imagery in the next verse suggests a kingdom of abundance. The blessing on Judah is the seed of the entire kingdom theology of the Old Testament.

Joseph's blessing is also notable. He receives a double portion through his two sons. He is described as a fruitful bough whose branches run over the wall. The blessings that came to him "are mighty beyond the blessings of my parents, up to the bounties of the everlasting hills." Joseph receives more, in some ways, than his fathers. The suffering son becomes the most blessed.

Then Jacob dies. The Egyptians mourn him for seventy days. Joseph and his brothers travel to Canaan with an enormous procession to bury Jacob in the cave of Machpelah. The covenant family does not stay in Egypt at death. They go home to the land of promise, even just to be buried there.

When they return, the brothers are afraid. They suspect Joseph has only been kind to them because Jacob was alive. Now that Jacob is dead, will Joseph take revenge? They send a message claiming Jacob's deathbed wish was that Joseph forgive them. Whether the message is true or fabricated is unclear. But Joseph weeps. And then he speaks one of the most theologically important sentences in the Old Testament. Genesis 50:20: "As for you, you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive, as they are today."

This sentence is the gospel of Genesis in miniature. Human evil is real. Divine purpose is real. Both are true at once. The same event, the brothers selling Joseph into slavery, was both wickedness (on their part) and providence (on God's part). The same will be true at the cross. The crucifixion of Christ was the most evil act in human history. It was also the most loving act of God in human history. The brothers crucified Christ. God meant it for good.

Genesis closes with Joseph's death. He is 110. He gathers his brothers around him and says, "God will surely visit you, and you shall carry up my bones from here." He is embalmed and placed in a coffin in Egypt. The coffin is the last image of Genesis. Not the promised land. Not victory. A coffin in Egypt. But Joseph has the eyes of faith. He knows God will visit. He knows the bones will be carried up. And four hundred years later, when the Exodus comes, Moses will indeed take Joseph's bones with him out of Egypt (Exodus 13:19). The faith of one man at the end of Genesis becomes the assurance of an entire nation's redemption.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis ends in suspense. The covenant family is in Egypt. The promise of the land is unfulfilled. Joseph's bones lie in a coffin. But the prophecy of Judah, "the scepter shall not depart", points all the way to Christ. The promise to Abraham is still operative. The God of the patriarchs has gone down to Egypt with them, and he will bring them up again. Everything that follows in the Bible flows from this moment.

STEP 6

Application

Make Genesis 50:20 your own theology. You will face evil in this life. Sins will be committed against you. Tragedies will strike. People will betray you. The Christian does not pretend these are good. They are evil. But the Christian also believes that God is at work behind every evil, not causing it, but ordering history so that even the worst events serve his redemptive purposes. The cross is the proof. The worst day in human history became the day of salvation. If God can do that with Calvary, he can do it with your story too.

And take heart from Joseph's coffin. He died in faith. He never saw the promised land. But he saw it by faith, and he trusted that God would visit his people. Some of God's promises will not be fulfilled in your lifetime. Some answers to your prayers will come after you are gone. The Christian does not need to see everything completed before death. We die in faith, trusting the God who keeps his word across generations.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give God the wrongs and losses you carry, and ask him to use them for the good of others.

Ask him to make you someone who weeps but forgives, suffers but trusts.

Pray that you would hold to his promise to the end of your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 9

"You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive."

GENESIS 50:20

DAY 60 · WEEK 9

Psalm 47

God has gone up with a shout, the universal king of all nations

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 47 twice. This is a short, exuberant psalm of God's kingship over all the nations. It is the perfect note on which to close the patriarchal narratives. The promise to Abram, that all nations would be blessed, finds its first hymn-form celebration here.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 47 is a short, festive psalm celebrating God's reign over all the nations. It was probably sung at one of Israel's major festivals, perhaps connected with the ascension of the king or the procession of the ark to the temple. It is one of the most joyful psalms in the Psalter and one of the most explicitly universal. The God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob is also the King of all the earth. The promise to Abram that "in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed" is the theological foundation of this psalm.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with a universal call: "Clap your hands, all peoples! Shout to God with loud songs of joy!"
2. Verse 2: "For the LORD, the Most High, is to be feared, a great king over all the earth." Universal kingship.
3. Verse 3: "He subdued peoples under us, and nations under our feet." Israel's victories are framed as God's reign.
4. Verse 4: "He chose our heritage for us, the pride of Jacob whom he loves." The patriarchal covenant celebrated.
5. Verse 5: "God has gone up with a shout, the LORD with the sound of a trumpet!" Image of divine ascension.

6. Verses 6-7 call repeatedly for praise: “Sing praises to God, sing praises!”
7. Verse 8: “God reigns over the nations; God sits on his holy throne.”
8. The psalm ends: “The princes of the peoples gather as the people of the God of Abraham. For the shields of the earth belong to God; he is highly exalted!”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 47 is one of the most joyful psalms in the entire Psalter, and it is precisely the right psalm to close out the patriarchal narratives. The whole point of God’s choice of Abraham was that, through one family, all nations would be blessed. Psalm 47 sings that promise as a present reality. The nations clap their hands. The peoples shout. God is king over all the earth.

The opening call is universal: “Clap your hands, all peoples!” Not just Israel. Not just the covenant family. All peoples. The psalmist is summoning every nation on earth to worship the God of Abraham. This is the Abrahamic Covenant set to music. The blessing that began with one man is meant for everyone.

Verse 2 declares the foundation: “The LORD, the Most High, is to be feared, a great king over all the earth.” Notice the divine name, El Elyon, God Most High. This is the very name used by Melchizedek when he blessed Abraham in Genesis 14. The same God who blessed Abraham is the great king over all the earth. The God who chose one family is also the God who reigns over every nation.

Verse 4 makes the patriarchal connection explicit. “He chose our heritage for us, the pride of Jacob whom he loves.” God’s choice of Jacob, the choice that has dominated the chapters we have been reading, is celebrated as his ongoing love for Israel. This is not contradiction to the universal scope. It is the means by which the universal blessing arrives. God chose one family in order to bless all families.

The image of verse 5 is striking. “God has gone up with a shout, the LORD with the sound of a trumpet!” This is the language of triumphal ascension, perhaps originally describing the ark being carried up to the temple, but in Christian reading, it has long been seen as pointing to Christ’s ascension. The same image will be used in Ephesians 4:8 about the risen Christ. The king has ascended. He reigns from above.

Then comes the repeated command: sing praises. Five times in two verses. The psalm cannot contain its joy. The God who reigns deserves praise from every voice.

Verse 8 is the theological climax: “God reigns over the nations; God sits on his holy throne.” This is one of the clearest statements in the Old Testament that God’s kingship is not local. He is not Israel’s tribal deity. He reigns over the nations. He sits on his holy throne. Every other throne is provisional. His alone is eternal.

And the closing verse: “The princes of the peoples gather as the people of the God of Abraham.” This is the climax of the whole patriarchal story. The princes of every people, the rulers of every nation, gather as members of the family of Abraham. The promise has come full circle. Through one family, blessing has come to all families. The God of Abraham is now the God of every nation that worships him.

STEP 5

Connection

We close Unit 3 with this psalm because it is the patriarchal promise in song. The covenant began with one man and one family. By Psalm 47, it has expanded, at least in vision, to embrace all the nations of the earth. Pentecost will be its first historical fulfillment. The new heavens and new earth, where “a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages” stand before the throne, will be its final fulfillment.

STEP 6

Application

Clap your hands. Shout to God with songs of joy. The God who chose Abraham is your God. The God who reigns over all the earth is your King. There is no nation outside his reach, no people group beyond his redemptive purposes, no enemy too strong for his throne. This should produce joy, not just gratitude, but exuberant celebration. The world’s news will tell you many other things. The truth is that God reigns. Let that truth restore your joy today.

And pray for the nations. The princes of the peoples gather as the people of the God of Abraham. Your prayer for missions, for unreached peoples, for nations that do not yet know the gospel, your prayer is in alignment with this psalm. Pray bigger than your own life today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God as king over all the nations, in your own words.

Ask him to restore your joy in his reign.

Pray for the gospel to reach people in a nation you rarely think about.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 9

"You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive."

GENESIS 50:20

DAY 61 · WEEK 9

Psalm 66:1-7

Shout for joy to God, all the earth

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 66:1-7 slowly, twice. This is the opening of one of the Psalter's great worship psalms. The first seven verses summon all the earth to praise God and recall his works of deliverance, particularly the Exodus. It is the right psalm to anticipate the next unit of our plan.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 66 is a great national psalm of thanksgiving. The first half (which we read today) calls all the earth to worship God for his mighty works. The second half (which the plan does not include here) gets more personal, recounting how the worshiper has tested God in suffering and been delivered. Today we read the public, corporate opening of the psalm. It looks back at the Exodus, which we are about to read in detail, and summons every nation to praise the God who made it happen.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 1: "Shout for joy to God, all the earth." Universal call to worship.
2. Verses 2-4: God's name and glory are to be celebrated by all peoples, even God's enemies will cringe before him.
3. Verse 5: "Come and see what God has done: he is awesome in his deeds toward the children of man."
4. Verse 6 specifically recalls the Exodus: "He turned the sea into dry land; they passed through the river on foot."
5. The crossing of the Red Sea and the Jordan are both alluded to, God's redemptive acts in history.

6 Verse 7: “Who rules by his might forever, whose eyes keep watch on the nations, let not the rebellious exalt themselves.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 66:1-7 is a call to worship grounded in God’s mighty acts of redemption. It is, in a sense, the opening anthem of the gospel of God’s deliverance.

The psalm opens by summoning the whole earth. “Shout for joy to God, all the earth.” Notice how universal the call is. This is not a private psalm for Israelites alone. It is a summons to every people, every nation, every voice on earth. Worship is meant to be global. God’s glory is not Israel’s private property; it is a flame that every nation should burn around.

Verses 2-4 connect God’s name with his glory. “Sing the glory of his name; give to him glorious praise!” The name of God is the focus of worship. Throughout the patriarchal narratives, we have seen God revealing his name in different forms, El Shaddai to Abraham, El Olam at Beersheba, the LORD at the burning bush (which we will read soon). The whole patriarchal story has been a gradual unveiling of who God is, and the appropriate response is worship of his name.

But then verse 3 has an arresting note: “Through the greatness of your power your enemies come cringing to you.” Worship is not just from the willing. Even God’s enemies eventually cringe before him. This is not the language of universalism (every soul finally saved) but of universal recognition (every knee will bow, whether in glad worship or fearful submission). The same will be expressed in Philippians 2 about Christ, “every knee should bow… and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord.”

Verse 5 invites the reader to look at history. “Come and see what God has done.” This is the basic posture of biblical faith. Look at what God has done. The patriarchal story is a record of what God has done. The Exodus is what God has done. The cross is what God has done. Faith is not blind. It looks at the deeds of God in history and worships in response.

And then verse 6 specifically recalls the Exodus: “He turned the sea into dry land; they passed through the river on foot. There did we rejoice in him.” The crossing of the Red Sea, and possibly also the crossing of the Jordan into the promised land, is mentioned as the supreme example of God’s redemptive power. This is the great event that defined Israel as a nation, and it is also the great picture that the New Testament will use for baptism, for salvation, for passing through death into life.

Verse 7 closes the section with a sober reminder. “Who rules by his might forever, whose eyes keep watch on the nations, let not the rebellious exalt themselves.” God reigns. He watches. The rebellious may make a lot of noise, but they should not exalt themselves. God’s

eyes are on the nations. Nothing escapes his rule. Whatever it looks like from the ground, the King is on his throne.

STEP 5

Connection

We are about to enter the Exodus narrative in the next unit. Psalm 66 is a fitting preview. It calls every nation to praise the God who turned the sea into dry land. The redemption of Israel from Egypt was not just a national story, it was a public demonstration of God's power that the whole world should learn from and worship in response to. The God of the Exodus is the God who still saves his people from every form of bondage.

STEP 6

Application

Take the psalmist's first command: shout for joy. The Christian life is meant to be full of joy in worship. Not somber acknowledgment, not dutiful gratitude, shouting joy. If your worship has gone quiet over time, let this psalm be a prophetic correction. The God who delivered Israel from Egypt is the same God who delivered you from sin and death. He deserves more than a polite thank-you.

And take the second command: come and see. Look at what God has done. Not just in Scripture, but in your own life. Make a habit of reviewing the redemptive acts of God on your behalf. The healings, the answered prayers, the prevented disasters, the spiritual breakthroughs. Come and see. Then sing.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Come and see what God has done, and tell him what you see in his work, from creation to the cross to your own life.

Ask him to restore your joy in worship.

Pray that the nations would join in praising him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 9

"You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive."

GENESIS 50:20

DAY 62 · WEEK 9

Review and Reflection

Unit 3 review, The Abrahamic Covenant

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."
>
> GENESIS 15:6

REST

Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and reflection on what you have learned in Unit 3.

Begin by memorizing the verse above if you have not already. Genesis 15:6 is the foundational verse of the doctrine of justification by faith. It is the verse Paul will quote in Romans 4 and Galatians 3 as the proof that justification has always been by faith, never by works of the law. Abraham believed God, and God counted it to him as righteousness. The transaction was simple, and it is the same transaction by which every Christian is justified today.

Say this verse aloud several times. Notice three things. First, Abraham believed. He did not earn, achieve, perform, or negotiate. He believed. Second, God counted it. The accounting is divine. God moves something from heaven's ledger into Abraham's account. Third, what God counted was righteousness. Not credit toward future righteousness. Not the possibility of righteousness. Righteousness itself. Abraham, who had lied about his wife, who had taken Hagar instead of waiting, who would lie again, Abraham was reckoned righteous because he believed.

This is your verse too if you are in Christ. You have believed. God has counted Christ's righteousness to you. You are reckoned righteous before the throne. Not because of your performance. Because you believed.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 3 you have traveled through Genesis 12 to 50, the entire patriarchal narrative. The unit began with the call of Abram, the great narrowing of God's redemptive plan to one man and one family through whom all nations would be blessed. You followed Abraham through his call, his journey, his lies, his rescue of Lot, his meeting with Melchizedek, the formal cutting of the covenant in Genesis 15, the institution of circumcision, the long-awaited birth of Isaac, and the binding of Isaac on Mount Moriah.

Along the way, the plan paused for the doctrine of Covenant Theology, naming the structure that runs throughout the Bible. Five covenants, one unfolding story, all fulfilled in Christ.

The unit then continued through Isaac's quieter life, Jacob's deception and flight, his vision of the ladder at Bethel, his twenty years with Laban, the formation of the twelve tribes through Leah, Rachel, and the maidservants, his wrestling with God at Peniel, his reconciliation with Esau, and the renewal of the covenant at Bethel.

The Joseph narrative dominated the second half of the unit. Joseph sold by his brothers, falsely accused by Potiphar's wife, forgotten in prison, finally elevated to second in command over Egypt, reuniting with his brothers, and forgiving them with the great theological summary: "You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good."

The unit closed with Jacob's death, his blessing of Judah (the scepter that would not depart), and Joseph's bones in a coffin in Egypt, awaiting the Exodus to come.

The Psalms accompanied the journey: Psalm 105 in two parts, summarizing the patriarchal story in song; Psalm 121 and the Psalms of Ascent, teaching us to walk by faith; Psalm 37, the wisdom of patience under apparent injustice; Psalm 47 and Psalm 66, the universal kingship of God over all nations.

The big theological lessons of this unit are these: God's covenant operates by election and grace, not by birth order or merit. Justification has always been by faith. God's promises take time, sometimes decades, and they are fulfilled in his way, not ours. God's providence works behind every event of human history, including the wickedness of others. And the line of Judah, the kingly tribe, runs all the way from Genesis 49 to Christ, the Lion of Judah, in whom every patriarchal promise finds its yes.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What are the three elements of God's promise to Abraham, and how does each find fulfillment in Christ?

Read Genesis 12:1-3 again. The three elements are land, offspring (a great nation), and universal blessing (all families of the earth blessed). Each finds fulfillment in Christ: the land is fulfilled in the new heavens and new earth, the offspring is fulfilled in Christ himself (Galatians 3:16, "to Abraham and to his offspring... who is Christ"), and the universal blessing is fulfilled in the gospel going to every nation. Write a few sentences in your own words about how the gospel today fulfills each element of God's promise to Abraham.

What does the covenant cutting of Genesis 15 reveal about the nature of God's grace?

Look back at Genesis 15. In the ancient Near East, both parties to a covenant walked between the cut pieces, pledging by self-curse to keep the covenant. But in Genesis 15, only God walks between the pieces. The covenant is one-sided. God binds himself to keep what he has promised, regardless of Abram's faithfulness. This is grace in its purest form, God taking on himself the entire weight of the covenant. Centuries later, Christ on the cross was torn like the animals in Genesis 15, bearing the curse so that God's people could be blessed. Sit with this. What does it mean for your assurance that God's covenant with you depends on his faithfulness, not yours?

How does the story of Joseph function as a type of Christ?

Walk through Joseph's life. He was the beloved son of his father (Genesis 37:3). He was hated and rejected by his brothers (37:4). He was sold for silver (37:28). He was wrongly accused and condemned (39:14-20). He was raised from the prison and given a name above every name in Egypt (41:39-43). He saved his brothers, including those who had sold him, by his elevation. He forgave them and provided for them. Every detail anticipates Christ. Take a moment to consider: in what specific ways did Joseph's suffering and exaltation point forward to Jesus' death and resurrection?

What does it mean that Abraham "believed God and it was counted to him as righteousness"?

Genesis 15:6, the most important Old Testament verse for understanding the New Testament's doctrine of salvation. Three things are happening here. First, Abraham believed, faith is the means of justification, not works. Second, God counted, the accounting is divine, not earned. Third, what was counted was righteousness, Abraham was reckoned righteous before God on the basis of faith alone, not on the basis of his moral performance (which had already failed and would fail again). Paul will use this verse in Romans 4 to prove that justification has always been by faith. If you have believed in Christ, this is true of you too. Pray through this. Thank God that you are reckoned righteous, not because of who you are, but because of who Christ is.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for keeping his promise to Abraham when no one else could.

Thank him that you are a child of Abraham through faith in Christ.

Ask him to keep the unit verse in front of you.

DAY 63 · WEEK 9

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. Yesterday closed Unit 3 with the review of the entire patriarchal narrative. Today closes the week with rest. The book of Genesis is now behind you. Take time today to feel the weight of what you have read, and to anticipate the Exodus to come.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive."

GENESIS 50:20

REST

Meditation

Genesis 50:20 is the theological climax of the entire patriarchal narrative, and of the entire book of Genesis. It is two sentences in one.

"You meant evil against me", the brothers' sin was real. Joseph does not minimize what they did. There is no false forgiveness here, no pretending nothing happened.

"But God meant it for good", behind their wickedness, God was working. Moving the pieces. Positioning Joseph in Egypt so that, when the famine came, many lives could be preserved. The same event was both wicked (on the brothers' part) and providential (on God's). Both are true at once.

This will eventually be said about the cross. The crucifixion of Christ was the most evil act in human history. It was also the most loving act of God in history. The same event. Both sentences true.

Carry this verse through your week. When you face injustice, remember it. When you mourn a wrong done to you, remember it. The God who turned Joseph's pit into a throne can do the same with your story.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week closed the patriarchal era and the book of Genesis. You read Judah's plea for Benjamin, the brother who once proposed selling Joseph now offering himself for the youngest. You watched Joseph reveal himself, weep, and forgive. You traveled with the family of Jacob down to Egypt and settled in Goshen. You read Jacob's prophetic blessings on his twelve sons, including the famous promise that the scepter would not depart from Judah. You watched Joseph die, his bones placed in a coffin in Egypt, awaiting the Exodus four hundred years later. You worshiped with Psalm 47 (God's reign over the nations) and the opening of Psalm 66 (all the earth called to praise). And yesterday you completed the Unit 3 review, anchored on Genesis 15:6, justification by faith.

Genesis is over. The patriarchal family is in Egypt. The four-hundred-year sojourning has begun. And the Lion of Judah stands over everything still to come.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Looking back at Genesis as a whole, where did your understanding of God deepen most? You have walked through 50 chapters in about 9 weeks. The book introduced God as Creator, Judge, Covenant-maker, Provider, the God of the patriarchs. Which face of God did you most need to see in this season of your life? Why?

How does Genesis 50:20 prepare you to read about the cross? When you reach the Gospels later in this plan, you will encounter the most evil act ever committed, and the most loving act God ever performed, in the same event. Joseph's words to his brothers are the theological key. Sit with this. How does the resurrection prove that what humans meant for evil, God meant for good?

What patriarchal failure most resembles your own? Genesis is candid about the failures of Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and Joseph's brothers. Lies. Favoritism. Manipulation. Betrayal. Drift. Where do you see your own story in theirs? And where do you see God's grace operating despite their (and your) failures?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for what you have seen of his hand through the book of Genesis.

Thank him that what others meant for evil he meant for good, supremely at the cross.

Ask him to give you Joseph's eyes for what lies ahead.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 4 · DAYS 64-93

Job: Suffering and Sovereignty

Job 1-42

Before the law, a righteous man suffers. God answers not with explanation but with himself.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For I know that my Redeemer lives, and at the last he will stand upon the earth."

JOB 19:25

Psalms of the suffering righteous (10, 13, 22, 73, 88, 17, and 26) beside Job.

UNIT 4

In this unit

WEEK 10

64	Job 1:1-2:13	*Reading*
65	Psalm 10	*Psalm*
66	Psalm 13	*Psalm*
67	Job 3:1-4:21	*Reading*
68	Job 5:1-7:21	*Reading*
69	Job 8:1-10:22	*Reading*
70	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 11

71	Job 11:1-13:28	*Reading*
72	Job 14:1-17:16	*Reading*
73	Psalm 22:1-21	*Psalm*
74	Psalm 22:22-31	*Psalm*
75	Job 18:1-20:29	*Reading*
76	Job 21:1-23:17	*Reading*
77	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 12

78	Job 24:1-26:14	*Reading*
79	Job 27:1-28:28	*Reading*
80	Job 29:1-31:40	*Reading*
81	Job 32:1-34:37	*Reading*
82	Job 35:1-37:24	*Reading*
83	Job 38:1-39:30	*Reading*
84	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 13

85	Job 40:1-42:17	*Reading*

86	Ephesians 1:11; Romans 11:33-36; Job 42:1-6	*Doctrine*
87	Romans 8:18-30; 1 Peter 4:12-19; 2 Corinthians 4:7-18	*Doctrine*
88	Psalm 73	*Psalm*
89	Psalm 88	*Psalm*
90	Psalm 17	*Psalm*
91	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 14

92	Psalm 26	*Psalm*
93	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 64 · WEEK 10

Job 1:1-2:13

The prologue in heaven; Job's suffering begins

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 42 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 1:1-2:13. This is the prologue, and it is the only place in the book where you are allowed to see behind the curtain. Read it as a story told in two settings: the courts of heaven and the ash heap on earth. Notice that Job never gets to read these two chapters.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

You have finished the Law and are now entering the wisdom literature. Job is probably the oldest story in this stretch of the Bible. The details point to the age of the patriarchs: Job's wealth is counted in livestock, he offers sacrifices as the head of his own household, and there is no mention of Israel, the exodus, or the law of Moses. The land of Uz lies outside the covenant people. That matters. God is showing you a man who knows him and fears him before the nations are sorted into Israel and everyone else. The book asks the oldest question people ask: why do the righteous suffer? And it will not let you answer too quickly.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job is introduced as "blameless and upright, one who feared God and turned away from evil" (1:1). The narrator tells you this before anything goes wrong.
2. Job is wealthy, with seven sons, three daughters, and enormous flocks. He also offers burnt offerings on behalf of his children, "for Job said, It may be that my children have sinned" (1:5).
3. The scene shifts to heaven, where the sons of God present themselves before the LORD, and Satan comes among them (1:6).
4. The LORD, not Satan, brings up Job: "Have you considered my servant Job?" (1:8).

5. Satan's accusation is that Job fears God only because God pays him for it, "Does Job fear God for no reason?" (1:9).

6. God sets a limit. Satan may touch what Job has but not Job himself (1:12). In chapter 2, he may touch Job's body but must spare his life (2:6).

7. Four messengers arrive one after another, and Job loses oxen, donkeys, sheep, camels, servants, and finally all ten of his children (1:13-19).

8. Job worships: "The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD" (1:21). The narrator adds, "In all this Job did not sin or charge God with wrong" (1:22).

9. Job's wife says, "Curse God and die" (2:9). Three friends arrive and sit with him in silence for seven days (2:11-13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing the prologue does is settle a question that the rest of the book will keep raising. Job's suffering is not a punishment for sin. The narrator says so, and God says so twice (1:8; 2:3). If you forget this, you will read the next thirty-nine chapters the way Job's friends do, looking for what Job must have done wrong.

The second thing the prologue does is show you that suffering has a larger setting than the person suffering. Satan appears as an accuser. His charge is a charge against God as much as against Job: that God's servants love him only because he pays them well, and that if the payment stops, so will the worship. The question on trial is whether God is worth loving for himself. Job does not know he is on trial. He does not know any of this is happening. That is a hard truth and a necessary one: sometimes the most important thing going on in your suffering is something you cannot see.

Notice the limits. Satan is not an equal of God. He cannot act until he receives permission, and the permission has a boundary every time. This is not a comfortable picture, because it means God is sovereign even over the hand that strikes Job. But it is also the only picture in which suffering has a limit and an end. The book will not explain to Job why God permitted it. It will show that God remained in charge.

Then look at Job's response. He tears his robe and shaves his head, which are the actions of real grief, and then he falls to the ground and worships. He does not pretend that nothing happened. He does not say that it is fine. He says that the LORD gave and the LORD has taken away, and he blesses the name of the LORD anyway. Chapter 2 sharpens the test. His wife,

who has lost everything too, tells him to give up. Job answers, “Shall we receive good from God, and shall we not receive evil?” (2:10). That is not cold stoicism. It is a man who has decided that God is not only a giver of gifts.

The last scene is the quietest. The friends sit with him for seven days and say nothing. It is the best thing they will do in the whole book.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus’ own story echoes Job’s. He too was declared righteous by the Father (“This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased”) and then led into suffering at the hand of the accuser (Matthew 3:17-4:11). Revelation 12:10 names Satan as “the accuser of our brothers.” James holds up Job as an example of steadfastness (James 5:11).

STEP 6

Application

First, if you are suffering now, hear that your suffering is not automatic proof of anything about you. Do not assume that God is angry, and do not assume that he is absent.

Second, remember that Satan has a leash. Nothing in your life, including the worst thing, falls outside the limits God sets.

Third, practice Job’s honesty. You can grieve openly and worship at the same time. Say the true thing about the pain and the true thing about God, and do not let either cancel the other.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that nothing touches your life beyond the limit he sets.
- Ask him to keep you from believing he has turned against you when you suffer.
- Pray for someone who is grieving today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 10

“The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD.”

JOB 1:21

DAY 65 · WEEK 10

Psalm 10

Where are you, LORD?, the lament when God seems hidden

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 10. After the prologue of Job, this is the psalm of someone who is living inside the silence. Read it slowly and listen for how the psalmist moves from accusation to confidence.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 10 was probably written by David, and in many ancient manuscripts it was joined with Psalm 9 as a single poem. Psalm 9 celebrates God's justice. Psalm 10 asks where that justice has gone. It is a lament about wicked people who seem to flourish while the poor are crushed. You have just watched Job lose everything while the wicked go on living. This psalm gives you words for what that feels like.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with two questions: "Why, O LORD, do you stand far away? Why do you hide yourself in times of trouble?" (v. 1).
2. The wicked man hunts the poor and boasts about his desires (vv. 2-3).
3. He does not seek God, and "all his thoughts are, There is no God" (v. 4).
4. He believes he will never be moved, and he treats God as if God has forgotten (vv. 5-6, 11).
5. His mouth is full of lies and oppression, and he lies in wait like a lion (vv. 7-10).
6. In verse 12 the psalmist cries, "Arise, O LORD; O God, lift up your hand; forget not the afflicted."

7. In verse 14 the psalmist says, “But you do see, for you note mischief and vexation.” The tone turns.

8. The psalm ends with confidence: “The LORD is king forever and ever” (v. 16), and he will “do justice to the fatherless and the oppressed” (v. 18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The honesty of this psalm is part of its gift. It begins with a question that sounds close to an accusation: why do you hide? The Bible does not tell you to suppress that question. It hands you a prayer that asks it out loud. Prayer in the Psalms is not polite. It is true.

The middle of the psalm is a portrait of the wicked, and the details are chilling. The wicked man is proud, he is a predator, and he has talked himself into believing that nobody is watching. “God will never see it” (v. 11). Look at what drives his behavior. It is not that he has weighed the evidence and decided God does not exist. It is that he wants the freedom to do what he wants without anyone looking. Practical atheism works like that.

Then the turn at verse 12. The psalmist does not receive an answer to his question. What he does is change what he asks for. “Arise, O LORD” is a petition, and the petition quickly becomes a confession: “But you do see.” The same God who seemed to be hiding is now the God who notes every wrong. The psalmist has not changed his circumstances. He has recalled who God is.

The last verses are certain. “The LORD is king forever and ever.” The wicked have a short reign, and God has a permanent one. The psalm ends with the fatherless and the oppressed, because they are the ones God is listening to. “O LORD, you hear the desire of the afflicted” (v. 17).

This is how lament works. It states the problem honestly, it asks, and then it lets the character of God answer. Job will do exactly this over the next thirty-five chapters.

STEP 5

Connection

The psalm describes the kind of arrogance that Paul quotes in Romans 3:14 (“Their mouth is full of curses and bitterness”), taken from verse 7. Jesus said that God will “give justice to his elect, who cry to him day and night” (Luke 18:7). Revelation 6:10 hears the martyrs ask the same question, “How long, O Lord?”

STEP 6

Application

If God feels distant right now, pray this psalm back to him word for word. Do not clean up the question. Then, as the psalmist does, say out loud one thing you know to be true of God: that he sees, that he is king, that he hears the afflicted.

Also, take note of who in your life is being crushed by someone more powerful, and ask what a God who hears the afflicted would want you to do.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God plainly where he seems far away.
- Pray for someone who is afflicted and ask how you might help.
- Ask him to strengthen your heart to wait.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 10

"The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD."

JOB 1:21

DAY 66 · WEEK 10

Psalm 13

How long, O LORD?, the short lament and its resolution

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 13. It has only six verses. Read it three times, once for each of its three movements: the questions, the plea, and the song.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is one of the shortest laments in the Psalter and one of the most loved. David wrote it, but we do not know the occasion. Some think it came during the years he was hunted by Saul. Others think it was an illness. The lack of detail is deliberate. The psalm is meant to be prayed by anyone who has asked God, "How long?" It follows Psalm 10 and goes with Job: both are about holding on to God when God seems to be silent.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The first two verses ask "How long?" four times: forgotten forever, hiding his face, taking counsel in my soul, my enemy exalted (vv. 1-2).
2. The psalmist says that God has forgotten him, and the sorrow is "in my heart all the day" (v. 2).
3. In verse 3 the psalm turns to commands: "Consider and answer me, O LORD my God; light up my eyes."
4. He fears death: "lest I sleep the sleep of death" (v. 3).
5. He fears that his enemy will say "I have prevailed" (v. 4).
6. Verse 5 begins with a contrast: "But I have trusted in your steadfast love."
7. The psalm ends in song: "I will sing to the LORD, because he has dealt bountifully with me" (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This psalm is built like a staircase. Each step is shorter than the last and leads upward. Verses 1 and 2 are four questions, and they are long and heavy. Verses 3 and 4 are three commands and a fear. Verses 5 and 6 are a statement of trust and a vow to sing. The rhythm of the poem acts out what happens in the heart of someone who prays honestly.

Pay attention to the phrase "How long?" It does not say "Why?" The question is not about the cause of the trouble. It is about duration. The psalmist can bear suffering for a season, but he cannot see an end to it, and that is what is crushing him. Many of us are in the same place. The pain is bearable only if it has a limit.

Then see what the psalmist asks for in verse 3. "Light up my eyes." He does not ask for a change in circumstances. He asks for sight. His eyes are going dim with grief, and he wants God to revive them. That is a prayer for perspective, and it is a good prayer.

The turn at verse 5 is the heart of the psalm. "But I have trusted." Nothing about the situation has changed between verse 4 and verse 5. The enemy is still there. God has not answered. What has changed is that the psalmist has chosen where to stand. He stands on God's "steadfast love," the covenant word, the word that means God will not walk away from his people. And from there he can do what seemed impossible in verse 1: rejoice and sing.

Notice that the song is a promise, not a report. "I will sing." He is singing before the rescue comes, and the reason he can is that he has already received something: God has dealt bountifully with him, and he is looking back on it.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus prayed a lament of his own on the cross, quoting Psalm 22:1. Paul said that "for those who love God all things work together for good" (Romans 8:28). Habakkuk 3:17-18 follows the same pattern: no fruit on the vines, yet "I will rejoice in the LORD."

STEP 6

Application

When you are asking "How long?", pray this psalm in the order it is written. State the pain honestly. Then ask God for light, not just for relief. Then say aloud, "But I have trusted in your steadfast love," and name one specific way you have seen that love in the past.

If you know someone who is waiting, send them verses 5 and 6 and tell them you are praying that they will sing again.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God “How long?” about the thing that weighs on you most.
- Remember aloud some ways he has been good to you.
- Tell him you trust him even here.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 10

“The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD.”

JOB 1:21

DAY 67 · WEEK 10

Job 3:1-4:21

Job curses the day; Eliphaz responds, suffering as punishment

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 3:1-4:21. Chapter 3 is Job's lament, and chapter 4 is the first speech of his friend Eliphaz. Read them as a conversation between a man in pain and a man with a theory.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After seven days of silence, Job finally speaks. What comes out is not a prayer to God and not a complaint about the friends. It is a wish to have never been born. The friends who sat silently beside him now begin to talk, and the rest of the book is a series of speeches. Most of Job is written in Hebrew poetry, and it is some of the most difficult poetry in the Bible. The speakers are not always right. The narrator does not tell you in each chapter who is right, so you must read with attention.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job begins, "Let the day perish on which I was born" (3:3). He wishes the day had been darkness.
2. He asks why he was not stillborn, and why light is given to those in misery (3:11-20).
3. He says that death would have meant rest, where "the wicked cease from troubling, and the weary are at rest" (3:17).
4. Job says, "For the thing that I fear comes upon me, and what I dread befalls me" (3:25).
5. Eliphaz begins gently, asking if Job will be impatient (4:2).
6. He reminds Job that he has comforted others (4:3-4).
7. Eliphaz states his principle: "Who that was innocent ever perished? Or where were the upright cut off?" (4:7).

8. He describes a night vision of a spirit that said, “Can mortal man be in the right before God?” (4:12-17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Start with Job’s lament. It would be easy to see it as a failure of faith. It is not. Notice who Job is not cursing. In verse 1 he curses the day of his birth, not God. He has not yet said anything against God. That restraint is easy to miss, and the narrator wants you to see that Job is still holding on even as he wishes he were dead.

The lament also shows how deep the grief is. Job does not want to die in order to be rid of God. He wants rest. “There the prisoners are at ease together” (3:18). He is exhausted. There is something very honest in this chapter, and the Bible makes room for it. You do not have to be strong in order to be faithful.

Then comes Eliphaz, and his first speech sounds reasonable. He is kind at first. He is trying to help. But he holds a theory, and the theory is stated in 4:7-8: the innocent do not perish, and “those who plow iniquity and sow trouble reap the same.” If Job is suffering, Job must have sinned. This is the principle of retribution, and it is true in a general way: sin has consequences, and wisdom tends to lead to life. Proverbs says so. But Eliphaz has taken a general truth and turned it into a rule that explains every single case. Job’s suffering does not fit the rule, and so Eliphaz must either change the rule or accuse Job.

The night vision is worth noticing too. Eliphaz claims a spiritual experience as proof. The message he reports, that no human is righteous before God, is true. Paul will say the same in Romans 3. But it is used wrongly here. It is a true statement that Eliphaz uses as a club.

Be careful to read this as a lesson on how to comfort. The friends could have kept silent. They could have wept. Instead they explained. Explaining pain to a person in pain, before you understand it, is not comfort.

STEP 5

Connection

Jonah also wished to die (Jonah 4:3), and so did Elijah (1 Kings 19:4), and God cared for both of them. Jesus rejected the same theory of retribution when his disciples asked whether a man’s blindness was caused by his sin or his parents’ (John 9:1-3). “Neither this man nor his parents sinned.”

STEP 6

Application

First, if you have said dark things to God in your pain, take comfort that Job did too, and that Scripture records it without rebuke.

Second, watch yourself when someone else is hurting. Before you offer a reason, offer your presence. Ask yourself whether you are trying to help them or to make yourself feel that the world is safe.

Third, test any belief that says "good people always get good things." It is not what the Bible says.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bring God your darkest thoughts without hiding them.

Ask him to keep you from explaining away another person's pain.

Ask him to teach you to sit with those who weep.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 10

"The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD."

JOB 1:21

DAY 68 · WEEK 10

Job 5:1-7:21

Eliphaz concludes; Job replies, the cry of the afflicted soul

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 74 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 5:1-7:21. Eliphaz finishes his speech in chapter 5, and Job answers in chapters 6 and 7. Notice the turn in chapter 7, when Job stops speaking to his friends and begins speaking to God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday Eliphaz began his speech with a general rule. Today he finishes it. His tone moves from correction to advice, and he gives Job a plan: seek God, accept discipline, and everything will be restored. He means well. But a plan of recovery assumes that Job did something wrong. Job's reply is the first long speech where he speaks both to his friends and to God, and it is one of the rawest passages in Scripture.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Eliphaz says, "Man is born to trouble as the sparks fly upward" (5:7).
2. He advises, "As for me, I would seek God, and to God would I commit my cause" (5:8).
3. He describes God as one who "does great things and unsearchable, marvelous things without number" (5:9) and who lifts the lowly (5:11).
4. He says, "Behold, blessed is the one whom God reproves; therefore despise not the discipline of the Almighty" (5:17).
5. Job answers, "Oh that my vexation were weighed" (6:2), and says his words have been rash because of his pain.
6. Job compares his friends to a seasonal stream that dries up in the heat when travelers need it (6:15-21).

7. He asks, “Teach me, and I will be silent; make me understand how I have gone astray” (6:24).

8. In chapter 7 he says, “My days are swifter than a weaver’s shuttle” (7:6) and “I will not restrain my mouth” (7:11).

9. He asks God, “What is man, that you make so much of him…that you visit him every morning and test him every moment?” (7:17-18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Eliphaz sounds wise because much of what he says is true. God does lift up the lowly. God does discipline those he loves. Later the writer of Hebrews will quote Proverbs about this very thing (Hebrews 12:5-6). The problem is that Eliphaz applies it to Job without knowing anything about Job’s case. The truth is real, and the application is wrong. That is one of the hardest things to learn about reading and using Scripture: a true statement can be false in a particular place.

Job’s reply begins with a plea for understanding. “Oh that my vexation were weighed.” He is not asking his friends to agree with him. He is asking them to see the weight of what he carries. And he makes an honest complaint about their help. They are like a wadi in the desert, running with water in the winter and gone in the heat. When a traveler most needs water, there is none. A friend’s faithfulness is measured in the dry season.

Then he makes a request that is entirely fair. “Teach me, and I will be silent.” He is open to correction. “How forceful are upright words! But what does reproof from you reprove?” (6:25). If they can show him a sin, he will listen. They cannot, because there is none to show.

Chapter 7 is where the speech changes direction. Job stops talking about his friends and begins talking to God. His language is bitter. He sees life as hard service and hired labor, he cannot sleep, and his skin is breaking. He asks God, “Am I the sea, or the sea monster, that you set a guard over me?” (7:12). He even parodies Psalm 8. Where David asked in wonder, “What is man that you are mindful of him?”, Job asks in pain what man is that God cannot leave him alone.

Do not read this as rebellion. Notice that Job is still speaking to God. The friends talk about God, and Job talks to him. That difference is the whole difference between theology as theory and faith as a relationship, and it is the reason God will say later that Job spoke rightly.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 12:5-11 quotes Proverbs 3:11-12 on discipline, and it is meant for children who are being trained, not for people who are suffering unjustly. Psalm 8 is the passage Job twists in 7:17-18, and Hebrews 2:5-9 reads Psalm 8 as fulfilled in Jesus. Psalm 88 will show you another prayer that does not end with comfort.

STEP 6

Application

When you read the Bible to comfort or counsel someone, ask whether the verse fits their situation, or whether you are using it to solve your own discomfort with their pain.

When you are the one in pain, pray as Job did. Speak to God, not only about him. If your prayers sound bitter, take them to the one person who can bear them.

Think of a person who was a seasonal stream for you, and one who was a river. Aim to be the second.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring your complaints to God and not around him.
- Ask him to make you a faithful friend in someone's dry season.
- Ask for wisdom to speak truth with love.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 10

"The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD."

JOB 1:21

DAY 69 · WEEK 10

Job 8:1-10:22

Bildad speaks; Job questions God's justice

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 8:1-10:22. Bildad speaks in chapter 8, and Job responds in chapters 9 and 10. Pay attention to the question Job asks in 9:2, because the whole book is about it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Bildad is the second friend to speak. Eliphaz relied on a personal experience. Bildad relies on tradition: what "the fathers" have taught. His speech is harder than Eliphaz's. He even suggests that Job's children died because of their own sin. Job answers with something new. He does not argue that he is innocent, but he asks a deeper question: even if a man were innocent, how could he ever win a case against God? He wishes there were someone to stand between them.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Bildad asks, "Does God pervert justice? Or does the Almighty pervert the right?" (8:3).
2. He says, "If your children have sinned against him, he has delivered them into the hand of their transgression" (8:4).
3. He tells Job that if he is pure and upright, God will rouse himself and restore him (8:5-6).
4. He appeals to the wisdom of earlier generations (8:8-10).
5. Job answers, "But how can a man be in the right before God?" (9:2).
6. He says that God is so powerful that no one can contend with him: "If it is a contest of strength, behold him! If it is a matter of justice, who can summon him?" (9:19).
7. Job says, "There is no arbiter between us, who might lay his hand on us both" (9:33).

8. In chapter 10 he addresses God directly: “I loathe my life…I will say to God, Do not condemn me; let me know why you contend against me” (10:1-2).

9. He asks God, “Did you not pour me out like milk and curdle me like cheese?” and remembers that God made him (10:10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Bildad’s mistake is cruel, though he does not mean it to be. He does what the friends all do: he turns suffering into a verdict. The death of Job’s children is, to Bildad, proof that they were guilty. It is hard to imagine a colder thing to say to a grieving father. But notice that Bildad believes he is defending God. His first question is a real one: “Does God pervert justice?” The answer is no, and Job would agree. The error is in thinking that he understands how God’s justice works in every case.

Job’s answer is much deeper. The question in 9:2 is the central one: “How can a man be in the right before God?” Job is not asking about his own sin. He is asking something bigger. God is so great and so strong that no human being could stand before him in court. Even if I were innocent, he says, my own mouth would condemn me. He sees clearly what Bildad does not: that the real problem between God and humanity is not a technical question about who deserves what. It is the distance between a holy God and a creature.

That leads Job to the most important wish in the chapter. “There is no arbiter between us.” He wishes for a mediator, someone with a hand on God and a hand on Job, who could bring them together. Job does not yet know that he is longing for a person God will one day send. He only knows that he needs one.

In chapter 10 his wild words turn into something like faith. He remembers that God made him, shaped him like clay, and knit him together with bones and sinews (10:8-12). The one who is attacking him is the one who made him. That memory does not remove the pain, but it makes the pain a question rather than a verdict: if you made me, why are you doing this?

This is one of the strange gifts of Job. He is allowed to ask the question without being told that the question is out of bounds.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that “there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus” (1 Timothy 2:5). Hebrews 9:15 says Christ is “the mediator of a new covenant.” Job’s cry for an arbiter finds its answer in Jesus, who has laid a hand on God and on us. The picture of God as potter is also in Isaiah 64:8 and Romans 9:20-21.

STEP 6

Application

Do not think that you can win an argument with God. Ask instead for the Mediator. Spend time thanking Jesus for being the one who stands between you and the Father.

Also, notice how easy it is to comfort yourself by finding a reason that other people suffer, such as "they must have done something." Resist that. Every time you catch yourself doing it, pray for the person instead.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what makes you feel unable to stand before him.
- Thank Jesus for being the mediator Job longed for.
- Ask him to make you gentle with those who suffer.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 10

"The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD."

JOB 1:21

DAY 70 · WEEK 10

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Spend your time with the memory verse. Read Job 1:21 slowly, three times, and then close your Bible and say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the review of the week, and choose one of the three questions to write about or to talk over with someone you trust.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD."

JOB 1:21

REST

Meditation

Job 1:21 is the confession of a man who has just lost everything. It is short enough to carry in your head, and heavy enough that it will take a lifetime to learn.

"The LORD gave." Job begins with gratitude. He has not forgotten what he received. The children, the land, the livestock, and the health were all gifts, and he names them as gifts. Everything good in your life is a gift too, and gratitude is the first step in learning to worship.

"And the LORD has taken away." This is the hard part, and Job does not soften it. He does not say that Satan took away, or that raiders took away, though both are true in the story. He sees through the second causes to the sovereign God who permits them. He does not say that God is guilty. He says that God is God. This is one of the most mature statements in Scripture, and it is not easy to say.

“Blessed be the name of the LORD.” The verse does not stop with the loss. It ends with praise, and the praise is aimed at the same LORD who gave and took. Job is not praising loss. He is praising the one who is greater than loss.

For the Christian, this verse takes on a new shape in light of the cross. The Father gave his Son, and the Son was taken away, and yet in that giving and taking is the greatest blessing in history. Job could not see that yet. You can.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began Unit 4 and the book of Job. You were taken behind the curtain into heaven, where Satan accused Job and God set a limit on what he could do. You watched Job lose his children and his wealth and his health, and you heard him worship. You read two laments, Psalm 10 and Psalm 13, which gave you words for the question “Where are you, LORD?” and the question “How long?” Then the friends arrived. You heard Eliphaz suggest that Job’s suffering must be the result of sin, and Bildad go further and say that Job’s children had earned their deaths. Job answered with grief, with bitterness, and with the first stirrings of a longing for a mediator. The week taught that suffering is not a verdict, and that faithful people are allowed to ask hard questions.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Job lost almost everything, and he worshiped. Is there something you have lost, or are afraid of losing, that you need to place again in God’s hands? Write down what it is, and then write “The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD” beside it.

How does Job’s longing for an “arbiter” who could stand between him and God (9:33) point you to Christ? Think about what it means that Jesus has laid his hand on both God and humanity. What would Job say if he could see the cross?

Which of Job’s friends do you most resemble when someone you love is hurting? What would it look like this week to sit silently with someone instead of offering explanations?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for what he has given, and place in his hands what you fear to lose.

Thank Jesus, the mediator Job longed for.

Rest in his care as the week ends.

DAY 71 · WEEK 11

Job 11:1-13:28

Zophar's rebuke; Job answers, I have heard all this before

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 11:1-13:28. Zophar, the third friend, speaks in chapter 11. Job's reply fills chapters 12 to 14, but you will read the first part today, ending at chapter 13. As you read, mark every place where Job turns from his friends to speak to God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Now all three friends have spoken once. Eliphaz argued from experience and Bildad argued from tradition. Zophar is the sharpest of the three, and he argues from sheer confidence. He tells Job that he knows what God is thinking. Job's answer begins with sarcasm and ends with one of the most daring statements of faith in the Bible. He will not give up on God, and he will not give up on the truth, and he is willing to say so to God's face.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Zophar asks, "Should a multitude of words go unanswered, and a man full of talk be judged right?" (11:2).
2. He wishes that God would speak and tell Job "that God exacts of you less than your guilt deserves" (11:6).
3. He asks, "Can you find out the deep things of God? Can you find out the limit of the Almighty?" (11:7).
4. He promises that if Job repents, "you will forget your misery" and "your life will be brighter than the noonday" (11:13-17).
5. Job answers with sarcasm: "No doubt you are the people, and wisdom will die with you" (12:2).

6. Job says, “I have understanding as well as you; I am not inferior to you” (12:3). He says he has become a laughingstock to his friends.
7. He describes God’s power over nations and rulers: “He makes nations great, and he destroys them” (12:23).
8. He calls the friends “worthless physicians” and “whitewashers” who lie on God’s behalf (13:4, 7).
9. Job says, “Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face” (13:15).
10. He asks, “Why do you hide your face and count me as your enemy?” (13:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Zophar’s speech is a good example of a sound idea turned into a weapon. His question in 11:7 is a good one. No one can fully search out God. But he uses it against Job in the wrong way. He says that God’s wisdom is so deep that Job cannot possibly know that he is innocent. That is a remarkable thing to say to a man who has lost his children. If God is that deep, then Zophar should be more careful about telling Job what God is doing.

Job’s sarcasm in chapter 12 is earned. “Wisdom will die with you.” He tells them that he knows everything they have said. The wise sayings about God’s power and justice are not secret. Everyone knows them. The problem is not information. The problem is that they use these truths to hurt him. And then he does what none of them has done: he describes God’s power honestly. God overthrows the mighty and strips kings of their robes (12:17-21). God is a God who is not predictable, and the friends’ tidy picture of divine justice cannot contain him.

Then comes chapter 13, and the most famous line in this section. “Though he slay me, I will hope in him.” The ESV translation reflects one reading of the Hebrew. Some translations read it as “Behold, he will slay me; I have no hope.” Either way, the verse is full of tension, and the next clause is clear: “yet I will argue my ways to his face.” Job is not giving up on God. He is going to bring his case before God directly. He knows that the godless cannot approach God, and the fact that he is willing to do so is itself evidence of his faith (13:16).

Look at the difference between Job and the friends. The friends talk about God. Job wants to talk to God. They defend God, as though he needed it. Job asks for an audience. He is the one who takes God seriously, and so he is the one who is willing to be honest with him.

This is a kind of faith that asks questions and keeps coming back. It is not a faith that is afraid of the answer.

STEP 5

Connection

The picture of faith that hopes in God even when he seems to be an enemy shows up again in Abraham, who believed that God could raise Isaac from the dead (Hebrews 11:17-19), and in Jesus in Gethsemane: “Not my will, but yours, be done” (Luke 22:42). Habakkuk 3:17-19 is another echo.

STEP 6

Application

Think of one question you are afraid to ask God. Ask it this week, honestly and respectfully, in prayer. Then keep listening.

Be careful of the kind of confidence that Zophar has. If you ever find yourself certain about why someone else is suffering, that is a sign to stop talking.

Consider memorizing Job 13:15 as your own statement of faith.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you do not understand about what he is doing.
- Ask him to give you honesty in prayer and humility to wait.
- Ask him to keep you hoping in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 11

“Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face.”

JOB 13:15

DAY 72 · WEEK 11

Job 14:1–17:16

"I know that my Redeemer lives"; the friends harden

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 14:1-17:16. Job reflects on the brevity of life, Eliphaz returns with a harsher speech, and Job answers by looking toward heaven for a witness. Read the speeches for the fragments of hope that keep breaking through.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first round of speeches is over, and the second begins. The friends are getting harder, not softer. Eliphaz tells Job that his own mouth condemns him, and he spends a whole chapter describing the miserable life of the wicked, which is a pointed way of saying that Job is suffering because he is wicked. Job's replies show someone who is wearing out. He has no hope in his friends and almost none in this life. But in the middle of the despair, he reaches for something he can hardly name: a witness in heaven.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job says, "Man who is born of a woman is few of days and full of trouble" (14:1).
2. He compares a person to a tree: "For there is hope for a tree, if it be cut down, that it will sprout again" (14:7), but man "lies down and rises not again" (14:12).
3. He asks, "If a man dies, shall he live again?" (14:14), and then expresses a hope that God would hide him in Sheol until his wrath has passed and then remember him.
4. Eliphaz accuses Job: "Your own mouth condemns you, and not I" (15:6).
5. Eliphaz describes the wicked man as one who "writhes in pain all his days" (15:20).
6. Job calls them "miserable comforters" (16:2) and says that God has worn him out (16:7).

7. Job says, “Even now, behold, my witness is in heaven, and he who testifies for me is on high” (16:19).
8. He pleads, “O earth, cover not my blood, and let my cry find no resting place” (16:18).
9. In chapter 17 he asks God to “lay down a pledge for me with yourself; who is there who will put up security for me?” (17:3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to notice is that Job’s questions are about more than his own pain. In chapter 14 he thinks about human life in general. We are short-lived, like a flower, and we are fragile. A tree that is cut down can sprout again from the stump. A person who dies seems to have no such hope. This is the darkest thought in the chapter, and it presses on Job until he asks the question that the rest of the Old Testament will slowly answer: “If a man dies, shall he live again?”

Then Job does something remarkable. He imagines that the answer could be yes. “All the days of my service I would wait, till my renewal should come” (14:14). He pictures God hiding him in Sheol like a man put away until a storm passes, and then calling to him. “You would call, and I would answer you; you would long for the work of your hands” (14:15). Job is not stating a doctrine of resurrection. He is imagining a possibility, and he is aware that it is a longing and not a certainty. But the longing is there, and it will grow.

Eliphaz’s second speech has no such moment. He is stuck in his system and he hardens. He says Job’s own mouth proves his guilt. He gives a long picture of the fate of the wicked. Notice that Eliphaz is not entirely wrong about the general truth. But it has become a trap for him and for Job.

Job’s answer in chapter 16 contains a shift. He first says that God is against him, which is where the pain is sharpest. But then, in 16:19, he turns to heaven. “My witness is in heaven.” He does not know who this witness is. It is another longing, like the arbiter of 9:33. Job has been wishing for someone who can speak for him before God. Now he is saying that such a person exists. God himself, in some mysterious way, will be Job’s advocate against God. It is a paradox and he does not resolve it.

Chapter 17 picks up the same thought. Job asks God to put up security for him, because no one else will. Only God can stand surety for Job against God.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul will say that Christ's resurrection answers Job's question: "But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep" (1 Corinthians 15:20). 1 John 2:1 says, "We have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous." Hebrews 7:22 says that Jesus became "the guarantor of a better covenant," the surety Job longed for.

STEP 6

Application

Spend time today thinking about the shortness of life. It can be a gift when it moves you to trust God, and it can be a burden when you use it as a reason to despair. Ask which one it is for you.

Remember that Jesus is the witness in heaven, the advocate, and the one who stood surety for you. Thank him specifically, and name something you needed an advocate for.

If you are tired of "miserable comforters," ask God to send you a faithful friend, and ask him to make you one.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God how worn out you are, if you are.
- Thank Jesus that because he lives, you will live.
- Ask him to send you comfort, and to make you a comfort to someone else.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 11

"Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face."

JOB 13:15

DAY 73 · WEEK 11

Psalm 22:1-21

My God, my God, why have you forsaken me

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 22:1-21. This psalm will be read twice in the next two days. Today, read the first half as the voice of someone in agony, and as you read, remember that Jesus quoted its first line from the cross.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 22 is attributed to David. We do not know the circumstances in which he wrote it, but the details of his suffering go far beyond anything we know of David's life. Hands and feet pierced, bones out of joint, clothes divided by lot. The New Testament sees these words as fulfilled in Jesus. The psalm is both a real prayer of a real man and a prophecy, and that is what makes it unique. It stands next to Job as one of the great statements of the suffering of a righteous person who feels forsaken.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm begins, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? Why are you so far from saving me, from the words of my groaning?" (v. 1).
2. He says he cries by day and by night, but there is no answer (v. 2).
3. Verses 3-5 turn to God's holiness and the fact that the fathers trusted in him and were delivered.
4. In verse 6 he says, "But I am a worm and not a man, scorned by mankind and despised by the people."
5. The crowd mocks him: "He trusts in the LORD; let him deliver him" (v. 8).
6. He remembers that God has been with him since birth (vv. 9-10).

7. Enemies surround him like bulls and lions (vv. 12-13, 16).
8. His body is poured out like water, his heart is like wax, and "my tongue sticks to my jaws" (vv. 14-15).
9. "They have pierced my hands and feet…they divide my garments among them, and for my clothing they cast lots" (vv. 16-18).
10. He pleads, "But you, O LORD, do not be far off!" (v. 19) and "Save me from the mouth of the lion" (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The most striking thing about the first line is the double name: "My God, my God." The psalmist feels forsaken, and in that moment he does not call God by a lesser name. He calls him "my God," twice. The sense of abandonment and the ownership of God sit side by side. This is the same paradox you saw in Job. The one who feels the most forsaken is the one who still says "my."

Verses 3 to 5 show how the psalmist uses memory as a weapon. He says, "Yet you are holy." He remembers that the fathers trusted God and were not put to shame. Memory is the way a person stays alive spiritually in a long night. When feeling fails, history holds.

Then the psalmist describes what it is like to be the object of contempt. "I am a worm and not a man." The crowd's mockery is the same sort of thing Job's friends do, only more brutal: "He trusts in the LORD; let him deliver him." The scorn of the crowd takes the very faith of the sufferer and turns it into a joke. That is a particular kind of pain, and the psalm gives it a name.

The physical description in verses 14 to 18 is overwhelming. And the language is so specific that the early church saw it as a portrait of the crucifixion. Crucifixion was not invented until centuries after David. Yet here are pierced hands and feet, bones out of joint, and a gambling match over clothing. The Gospels do not hide the fact that they are quoting this psalm. John 19:23-24 cites verse 18 directly.

The first half of the psalm ends in the cry of verses 19 to 21. It is still a cry. The rescue has not come yet. But the shift is already beginning, because the psalmist is asking God for help in the second person: "But you, O LORD." The turn happens in the next verse, and you will read it tomorrow.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus cried Psalm 22:1 from the cross (Matthew 27:46). The mockery in verse 8 is repeated by the chief priests (Matthew 27:43). The division of garments in verse 18 is quoted in John 19:24. Hebrews 5:7 says that Jesus "offered up prayers and supplications, with loud cries and tears, to the one who was able to save him from death."

STEP 6

Application

The next time you feel forsaken, use these words. Jesus prayed them before you, and so you are never praying alone. He knows the feeling from the inside.

Take time today to thank him for bearing the real abandonment, so that you might never be forsaken by the Father. Be specific. What did he take on himself?

If you are watching someone else suffer, do not mock their faith, even gently. Ask yourself whether a quick word of religious cheer is really a kind of mockery.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being forsaken so that you would not be.
- Tell God where you feel far from him.
- Thank him that he is near now.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 11

"Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face."

JOB 13:15

DAY 74 · WEEK 11

Psalm 22:22-31

I will tell of your name, lament turns to praise

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 22:22-31. Yesterday ended with a cry. Today the cry turns into praise. Read these verses aloud and notice who is included in the praise at the end.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

There is a break in Psalm 22 at verse 21. In Hebrew, the last words of that verse are something like "You have answered me." The psalmist has been rescued. Everything after that point is a different kind of song. The man who was forsaken now tells others what God has done, and the song grows wider and wider until it takes in the whole earth and generations that have not yet been born.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalmist says, "I will tell of your name to my brothers; in the midst of the congregation I will praise you" (v. 22).
2. He calls the congregation to praise: "You who fear the LORD, praise him!" (v. 23).
3. The reason: "For he has not despised or abhorred the affliction of the afflicted, and he has not hidden his face from him, but has heard, when he cried to him" (v. 24).
4. He vows to fulfill his vows in the presence of those who fear God (v. 25).
5. "The afflicted shall eat and be satisfied; those who seek him shall praise the LORD" (v. 26).
6. "All the ends of the earth shall remember and turn to the LORD, and all the families of the nations shall worship before you" (v. 27).
7. "Kingship belongs to the LORD, and he rules over the nations" (v. 28).

8. Even the dead are included: “All the prosperous of the earth eat and worship; before him shall bow all who go down to the dust” (v. 29).

9. The psalm ends with a future generation hearing about it: “that he has done it” (v. 31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Look at what the sufferer does the moment he is rescued. He does not keep it private. “I will tell of your name to my brothers.” The rescue is a story, and a story is for telling. This is the way the Bible thinks of salvation: it is not only something that happens to a person. It becomes something the community knows and celebrates.

Verse 24 is worth stopping at. It is the answer to the first line of the psalm. Back in verse 1, God seemed to have forsaken the psalmist and hidden his face. Now he says, “He has not hidden his face from him.” What looked like abandonment turned out not to be. In the middle of the darkness, God was hearing. That does not mean that the suffering was unreal. But it means that the suffering was never the last word about God’s attitude.

The scope of the praise is dizzying. From one man in agony, we move to the congregation, then to the afflicted who eat and are satisfied, then to all the ends of the earth, then to all the families of the nations, and then to the dead and the unborn. One sufferer’s deliverance becomes the occasion for the worship of the whole world. This is the shape of the gospel. Through one man’s suffering and vindication, the nations are gathered.

That is why the New Testament reads Psalm 22 as the story of Jesus. Hebrews 2:12 puts verse 22 in Jesus’ mouth: “I will tell of your name to my brothers; in the midst of the congregation I will sing your praise.” The risen Jesus calls his people brothers, and he sings with them. The psalm that begins in the loneliest hour of history ends with a Savior who is surrounded by a people he has redeemed.

The last verse is also worth keeping. “They shall come and proclaim his righteousness to a people yet unborn, that he has done it.” Those words reach all the way to you.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 2:10-12 applies verse 22 to Jesus and his brothers. Revelation 7:9 pictures the fulfillment of verse 27: “a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages.” Jesus’ last words from the cross in John 19:30, “It is finished,” may echo the final words of Psalm 22:31, “that he has done it.”

STEP 6

Application

Tell someone this week what God has done for you. It does not need to be dramatic. Practice saying, “Let me tell you what the LORD did.”

Also think about the nations. Is there a mission or missionary you could pray for or give to in light of verse 27? Choose one.

If you are in a hard season, return to verse 24 and ask God to help you believe it before you see it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he has not hidden his face from you.
- Ask him for words to tell what he has done.
- Pray that he would gather people from every nation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 11

“Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face.”

JOB 13:15

DAY 75 · WEEK 11

Job 18:1-20:29

Bildad and Zophar intensify; Job's redeemer confession

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 18:1-20:29. Bildad and Zophar both make speeches, and between them Job gives a speech in chapter 19 that contains the most famous words in the book. Read chapter 19 slowly, and read verses 23 to 27 aloud.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second cycle of speeches, and the friends are escalating. Bildad's second speech is a chilling portrait of the fate of the wicked. Zophar's is much the same. The emotional force behind their words is fear: if Job is innocent, then their whole picture of the world is broken. So they must make him guilty. In the middle comes Job's answer, in which he is crushed, isolated, and accused, and out of the dark he says the thing for which the book is best known.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Bildad says, "Is the earth to be forsaken for you, or the rock to be removed from its place?" (18:4).
2. He describes the wicked as trapped, terrified, and forgotten, and says, "He has no offspring or descendant among his people" (18:19).
3. Job answers, "How long will you torment me and break me in pieces with words?" (19:2).
4. He says that God has wronged him and walled up his way (19:6-8).
5. Job's family and friends have abandoned him, and even young children despise him (19:13-19).

6. “Have mercy on me, have mercy on me, O you my friends, for the hand of God has struck me!” (19:21).
7. “Oh that my words were written! Oh that they were inscribed in a book! Oh that with an iron pen and lead they were engraved in the rock forever!” (19:23-24).
8. “For I know that my Redeemer lives, and at the last he will stand upon the earth” (19:25).
9. “And after my skin has been thus destroyed, yet in my flesh I shall see God, whom I shall see for myself, and my eyes shall behold, and not another” (19:26-27).
10. Zophar answers that the joy of the wicked is short (20:5), and that what they gain will be vomited up (20:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Bildad and Zophar use pictures that are meant to frighten. Their descriptions of the wicked person’s end are among the most vivid in the Bible. There is a light that goes out, a net that closes, terrors that chase him. But they are describing Job without saying his name. This is a kind of cruelty that wears the clothes of wisdom.

The speech Job gives in response is full of heartbreak. He lists everything he has lost in relationships: his brothers have estranged themselves, his close friends have forgotten him, his servants do not answer him, and his wife finds his breath strange. Even young boys despise him. To lose possessions is hard. To lose belonging is harder. Job begs his friends, “Have mercy on me.”

And then, out of this, comes the most astonishing section in the book. Job wishes that his words could be written down forever. He wants a permanent record, because he knows that his death will come before he has been vindicated. The words that follow are not a wish, though. They are a statement of certainty: “I know that my Redeemer lives.”

The Hebrew word for Redeemer is go’el, a legal term for the family member who rescues a relative in need: who buys back land lost to debt, who avenges a death, who protects the vulnerable. Job’s longing in chapter 9 for an arbiter and in chapter 16 for a witness has now become a conviction. He does not just hope for someone. He knows there is someone, and he calls that person a living Redeemer who “will stand upon the earth,” as though taking his place in a courtroom at the last.

And then the most daring part. “Yet in my flesh I shall see God.” Job expects to see God with his own eyes, after death, in his body. Whether he fully understood what he was saying is debated. But the words, set in the canon, carry a hope of bodily resurrection that is not fully

revealed until the New Testament.

Notice that the verse is spoken from the lowest point of the book. Hope is not the fruit of good circumstances. It is a decision made in the dark.

STEP 5

Connection

Boaz acts as a go'el in the book of Ruth, which you will read in Unit 8. Isaiah calls God Israel's Redeemer many times (Isaiah 41:14; 43:14; 54:5). Paul says in 1 Corinthians 15:51-57 that the dead will be raised imperishable. Jesus says, "I am the resurrection and the life" (John 11:25). Job's hope is realized in the risen Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Job 19:25 this week. It is the unit's theme verse. Say it aloud in the morning and at night.

Think about the Redeemer you have. What did Jesus do to buy you back, and what did it cost? Write a short paragraph about it.

If you have lost something in a relationship, say so honestly to God. Then ask him to hold the loss in his hand.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you believe about your Redeemer, in your own words.
- Ask him to anchor you in that hope when loss surrounds you.
- Thank Jesus for standing for you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 11

"Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face."

JOB 13:15

DAY 76 · WEEK 11

Job 21:1-23:17

Job confronts the prosperity gospel; God seems far

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 21:1-23:17. Job answers Zophar and challenges the friends' theory about the wicked. Eliphaz replies in chapter 22 with a direct accusation, and Job answers in chapter 23 with a longing to find God. Read chapter 23 as a prayer.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The friends have claimed that the wicked always suffer and the righteous always prosper. Job's answer in chapter 21 is simple and devastating: look around. In this world, wicked people often grow old, wealthy, and secure, and nothing happens to them. The friends' theory does not match what we see. This is the point where Job's book speaks most plainly against any teaching that promises health and wealth to those who follow God faithfully. Then comes a longing, one of the most moving in the book: Job wants to find God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job says, "Why do the wicked live, reach old age, and grow mighty in power?" (21:7).
2. He describes their children as secure, their herds as fertile, and their houses as safe (21:8-13).
3. The wicked say to God, "Depart from us!" and ask, "What is the Almighty, that we should serve him?" (21:14-15).
4. He says that both rich and poor die and lie down in the dust together (21:23-26).
5. Eliphaz now accuses him of specific sins: "Is not your evil abundant? There is no end to your iniquities" (22:5). He claims Job has not given water to the weary or bread to the hungry (22:7).

6. Eliphaz urges, “Agree with God, and be at peace; thereby good will come to you” (22:21).
7. Job says, “Oh, that I knew where I might find him, that I might come even to his seat!” (23:3).
8. “Behold, I go forward, but he is not there, and backward, but I do not perceive him” (23:8).
9. “But he knows the way that I take; when he has tried me, I shall come out as gold” (23:10).
10. “I have not departed from the commandment of his lips; I have treasured the words of his mouth more than my portion of food” (23:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 21 is the strongest rebuttal of the idea that faithful living guarantees comfort. Job takes the friends’ favorite claim and demolishes it with evidence. If the wicked always fall, why do so many seem to thrive? His statement is not an invitation to envy. It is an observation about the world as it is, and it agrees with what Psalms 37 and 73 say. Both say that the wicked prosper for a time, and that God’s justice has a different clock.

That matters for how you read the Bible. Proverbs makes general statements about wisdom leading to life. Job reminds you that those are not guarantees. A teaching that says “follow God and you will be healthy and rich” will break the first time it meets a Job. The Bible does not teach that.

Eliphaz’s response is the low point for the friends. He cannot answer Job’s evidence, so he invents charges. Job has never been accused of mistreating the poor, and the narrator has said that he is blameless. But in order to keep his theory, Eliphaz needs Job to be guilty, and so he makes up sins. This is what happens when a doctrine matters more than a person. It starts to lie.

Then Job goes quiet in a new way. In chapter 23 he stops arguing with the friends. He just wants God. “Oh, that I knew where I might find him.” His problem is not exactly that God is angry. It is that God is missing. He looks forward, backward, to the left and right, and he cannot see him. This is the experience of many believers in dark seasons, and it is described here without a trace of blame.

Yet there is trust in the middle of the darkness. “He knows the way that I take.” Job cannot see God, but God can see him. And “when he has tried me, I shall come out as gold.” It is not a claim that he deserves it. It is a confidence that God’s testing has a purpose and an end. Alongside that is his devotion to God’s word: he has treasured it more than his food.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 73, which you will read soon, struggles with the same puzzle of the prosperity of the wicked. Jesus said that God "makes his sun rise on the evil and on the good, and sends rain on the just and on the unjust" (Matthew 5:45). 1 Peter 1:6-7 speaks of faith "tested by fire" being "found to result in praise and glory and honor." James 5:11 holds up Job's endurance.

STEP 6

Application

Test any teaching you hear against the book of Job. If it promises that obedience will always bring health and wealth, it is not the teaching of the Bible.

When you cannot find God, pray Job 23:10 and ask him to hold you until you can see him again.

If you are in a season of dryness, treasure his words more than your food. Put your Bible reading first this week, before breakfast.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God honestly where you cannot find him.
- Ask him to refine you through what you are going through.
- Ask him to help you treasure his word above comfort.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 11

"Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face."

JOB 13:15

DAY 77 · WEEK 11

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Job 13:15 aloud, slowly, several times, and then try to say it from memory. Read the meditation and the review of the week, and then pick one of the three questions for writing, prayer, or conversation.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face."

JOB 13:15

REST

Meditation

Job 13:15 is the sentence of a man who refuses two temptations at once.

The first temptation is to give up on God. Job has every reason to say that God is not good, that faith is a mistake, and that his friends were right about God being a tyrant. Instead he says, "I will hope in him." The verb is the verb of waiting, of leaning, of staking everything on someone. And the "though" in front of it makes the hope costly. It does not wait for the circumstances to improve. It hopes while the worst is happening.

The second temptation is the opposite one: to pretend. The friends have told Job to be quiet and humble and accept his guilt. He refuses that too. "Yet I will argue my ways to his face." He will not fake agreement. He is going to bring his case before God, in full honesty. His faith is not the silence of someone who has stopped asking. It is the courage of someone who believes that God can be asked.

Together, the two halves give you a picture of mature faith. It is not a calm faith that has no questions. It is a faith that has questions and takes them to God. Many of the saints have prayed this way. Learn it by heart, because you may need it in a hard season.

For the Christian, there is a final note. Jesus said something very close to this in the garden. He asked that the cup be taken from him, and he also said that the Father's will be done. He hoped in the Father even though the Father would slay him, and the Father raised him up.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the middle of the book of Job. You heard Zophar tell Job that he cannot know the mind of God, and Job answer that he has no intention of giving up on God or on the truth. You read Job's meditation on the shortness of life and his dim hope that a man who dies might live again. You read Psalm 22, the great cry of the forsaken and the song of the rescued, and you saw how Jesus prayed it from the cross. Then Bildad and Zophar piled on, and in the middle of the pain Job said, "I know that my Redeemer lives." By the end of the week, Job was confronting the idea that the righteous always prosper, and longing to find God. The week taught that real faith asks, waits, and still holds on.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Which is harder for you right now: to keep hoping in God when things go badly, or to bring him your honest questions? Write about what has made it difficult, and what one small step you could take.

How does Psalm 22, and the way Jesus prayed it, change the way you hear Job's cry? What does it mean that the Redeemer Job longed for has been through the loneliest night himself?

Think of a person in your life who needs a faithful friend, someone who will not give easy answers. What could you do for them this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God where you want to hope in him even though you do not understand.

Thank him for the Redeemer who walked the darkest night before you.

Rest in his care this Sabbath.

DAY 78 · WEEK 12

Job 24:1-26:14

Why are times not kept by the Almighty? Bildad's last word

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 24:1-26:14. Job begins by asking why God does not set times for judgment, Bildad gives his last, very short speech, and Job answers with a hymn to God's power. Read chapter 26 as a poem about how little we know.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the third and final cycle of speeches, and you can feel the friends running out of things to say. Eliphaz has spoken already. Bildad has only six verses left in him, and Zophar will not speak at all. Job's side of the argument keeps growing. In these chapters he first lists injustices that God seems to ignore, and then he turns and praises God's greatness with a sweep and beauty that exceeds anything the friends have said. The man who is accused of doubting God is the one who describes him best.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job asks, "Why are times not kept by the Almighty, and why do those who know him never see his days?" (24:1).
2. He lists the oppressed: the poor driven from the road, orphans taken as a pledge, and laborers who go hungry while they carry the sheaves (24:2-12).
3. He says, "From out of the city the dying groan, and the soul of the wounded cries for help; yet God charges no one with wrong" (24:12).
4. Bildad asks, "How then can man be in the right before God? How can he who is born of woman be pure?" (25:4).
5. He calls man "a maggot" and "a worm" (25:6).

6. Job answers sarcastically: “How you have helped him who has no power!” (26:2).
7. He says, “Sheol is naked before God, and Abaddon has no covering” (26:6).
8. God “stretches out the north over the void and hangs the earth on nothing” (26:7).
9. “Behold, these are but the outskirts of his ways, and how small a whisper do we hear of him! But the thunder of his power who can understand?” (26:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 24 is a hard chapter to read because it is so honest about injustice. Job does not look away. He describes the poor picking through the leftovers of the rich, children taken as collateral, and the dying crying out in the city. And he says, “God charges no one with wrong.” This is a startling thing for a man of faith to say, but it is true to the way the world looks. Injustice happens, and it seems to go unnoticed. Job is saying what the psalmists say.

It is worth asking what he is asking for. He does not say that God does not exist, and he does not say that God is cruel. He says that the times are not “kept,” that the schedule of judgment is hidden from those who know God. That is a question about timing. And it points forward to a day of judgment, which Job will keep longing for.

Bildad’s speech is a sign that the friends are exhausted. His point in chapter 25 is that no human being is pure before God. That is true, and the New Testament will say it too. But look at what he does with it. He uses it to put Job down, in the cruel language of “maggot” and “worm.” Human weakness is a truth that is supposed to humble us before God. It is not supposed to be used as an insult.

And then Job speaks, and you can hear how much better a theologian he is. He answers Bildad’s short speech with a long, majestic description of God’s power: Sheol is open before him, the earth hangs on nothing, the clouds hold water without bursting, and the pillars of heaven tremble at his rebuke. He ends with a humble line that the friends could never say: “These are but the outskirts of his ways.” Even all of this is only the edge of what God is. We hear a whisper. The thunder is beyond us.

This is the proper stance of a creature. Job is not claiming to understand. He is claiming to trust a God who is bigger than his questions.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 94 asks God, “O LORD, how long shall the wicked exult?” Habakkuk 1:2-4 asks the same question about injustice. Paul says in Romans 11:33 that God’s ways are “unsearchable,” and in 1 Corinthians 13:12 that “now we see in a mirror dimly, but then face to face.” Revelation

6:10 and 19:2 show God answering the cry for justice.

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of injustices that weigh on you, in your own life, your community, or the world. Do not rush to resolve them. Take them to God as Job does.

Notice whether you tend to use humility as an insult, either toward yourself or toward others.

Then end by praising God for something in creation you cannot explain: the stars, the ocean, or the birth of a child. Remember that these are only the outskirts of his ways.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring an injustice you see to God.
- Thank him that he will one day judge the world in righteousness.
- Ask him to make you someone who acts with justice and mercy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 12

"Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding."

JOB 28:28

DAY 79 · WEEK 12

Job 27:1-28:28

Job's integrity; the hymn to wisdom, where shall it be found?

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 59 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 27:1-28:28. Job holds to his integrity in chapter 27, and in chapter 28 there is a famous poem about wisdom. Notice how the poem is built: first a long description of what human beings can find, then a question about what they cannot.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Zophar has not replied, and the three friends fall silent. Job speaks on, and in the next three chapters he gives his final defense. Chapter 27 is a vow to keep his integrity. Chapter 28 is different in tone and in kind. It is a hymn on wisdom that sounds almost like Proverbs, and some scholars think it is the narrator's own voice. Whatever its source, it is placed at the center of the book, and it gives the book's central answer to the question of how a person can find wisdom in a world of suffering.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job swears an oath: "As God lives, who has taken away my right, and the Almighty, who has made my soul bitter" (27:2).
2. He says that as long as he has breath, "my lips will not speak falsehood" (27:3-4).
3. "Far be it from me to say that you are right; till I die I will not put away my integrity from me" (27:5).
4. "I hold fast my righteousness and will not let it go; my heart does not reproach me for any of my days" (27:6).
5. Chapter 28 begins with mining: "Surely there is a mine for silver, and a place where gold is refined" (28:1).

6. Humans dig “a shaft in a valley away from where anyone lives” and “overturn mountains by the roots” (28:4, 9).
7. “But where shall wisdom be found? And where is the place of understanding?” (28:12).
8. It cannot be bought for gold or silver or onyx or sapphire (28:15-19).
9. “God understands the way to it, and he knows its place” (28:23).
10. “Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding” (28:28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 27 is Job’s refusal to be pushed into a false confession. The friends have told him many times to repent, and he cannot, because he knows that he has not done what they say. He is not claiming to be sinless. He is saying that he did not bring this suffering on himself. To say otherwise would be to lie, and he will not lie even to please God, because he believes that God does not want his lies. This is a quiet kind of courage.

Then chapter 28 shifts the whole mood. The poem begins by describing the astonishing ability of human beings. We dig deep into the earth, we find silver and gold and sapphires, we reach places where birds and lions have never been. There is nothing human beings cannot find with enough labor. This is the picture of a technological, adventurous people.

And then the poem asks the question that all of that effort cannot answer: “But where shall wisdom be found?” It is hidden even from the eagle and the vulture. You cannot buy it. You cannot mine it. Death and the Abyss say, “We have heard a rumor of it.” The whole point of the poem is that wisdom is not something people can find by digging. It is not an object. It belongs to God.

The answer, which comes in verse 23, is that God knows its place, because God made the world by it. And then verse 28 states what he has told humankind: “The fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding.” This is the same line that opens the book of Proverbs (1:7). It is where wisdom begins and also where it ends.

Placed here, in the middle of Job’s suffering, the verse is a challenge and a comfort. Job does not have answers about why he is suffering. But he is being told that wisdom is not the same as having answers. It is fearing God, and refusing evil, in the dark.

STEP 5

Connection

Proverbs 1:7 and 9:10 open and close their wisdom with the same line as verse 28. In the New Testament, Christ is "the wisdom of God" (1 Corinthians 1:24), and in him "are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" (Colossians 2:3). James 1:5 invites us: "If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask God, who gives generously to all."

STEP 6

Application

When you are tempted to say what is easy rather than what is true, remember Job. Your integrity is worth protecting. Ask God for the courage to say true things even when it costs you.

Think about where you go for wisdom. Is it a podcast, a person, a book? Ask whether you are first going to God and his word.

Pray that the "fear of the Lord" becomes your first instinct, and not just a phrase.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God where you need wisdom you cannot find on your own.
- Ask him for a heart that fears him and turns from evil.
- Thank Jesus, in whom all wisdom is found.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 12

"Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding."

JOB 28:28

DAY 80 · WEEK 12

Job 29:1-31:40

Job's final defense, his past, his suffering, his oath

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 29:1-31:40. This is Job's final speech to his friends. It has three parts: a look back at his happier past, a description of his present humiliation, and an oath of innocence. It is long, so read it in three sittings if you need to.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Job's last speech is like a legal brief. He lays out what his life was before, what it is now, and why he believes he is not at fault. It reads like an honest man's last defense in court. He does not insult his friends in this section, and he does not curse God. He sets out his case, and then he asks God to answer. The chapters are long, but they give you the most complete portrait of Job as a person in the whole book.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job longs for "the months of old, as in the days when God watched over me" (29:2).
2. He remembers his authority in the city gate. The young men stepped back, and the old men rose when he came (29:7-8).
3. He rescued "the poor who cried for help, and the fatherless who had none to help him" (29:12).
4. He says, "I was eyes to the blind and feet to the lame. I was a father to the needy" (29:15-16).
5. Now he is mocked by those whose fathers he would not have put with the dogs of his flock (30:1).

6. “I cry to you for help and you do not answer me; I stand, and you only look at me” (30:20).
7. “You have turned cruel to me; with the might of your hand you persecute me” (30:21).
8. “I made a covenant with my eyes; how then could I gaze at a virgin?” (31:1).
9. He swears that he has not been unjust to his servants, has not withheld food from the poor, has not trusted in gold, and has not rejoiced at an enemy’s ruin (31:13-30).
10. “Oh, that I had one to hear me! (Here is my signature! Let the Almighty answer me!)” (31:35). “The words of Job are ended” (31:40).

STEP 4

Interpretation

There is something moving in chapter 29. The picture of Job as the one who defended the weak is a picture of a man who really loved justice. He did not simply enjoy a position. He used it to rescue the poor. He describes himself as clothed in righteousness and justice like a robe. Nothing here is false. The narrator told you that Job was blameless, and this is what blamelessness looked like in practice.

But look at what he misses most. It is not wealth or status. It is the sense that God was watching over him. “When the Almighty was yet with me” (29:5). The loss of God’s felt presence hurts more than the loss of his children or his health. That is the right order of grief.

Chapter 30 is the opposite picture. Those who once respected him now spit at him. He says that God has become cruel to him. That is a severe statement and the narrator does not correct it here. In fact, Job is describing how things feel. He may not be right about God’s intentions, but he is honest about his experience. The Bible lets him say it.

Chapter 31 is the longest oath in the book. It is a series of “if I have” statements: if I have lusted, if I have been dishonest, if I have been unjust to my servants, if I have ignored the poor, if I have put my trust in money. Each one calls down a curse on himself if it is true. This is how people in the ancient world swore to their innocence. And look at what is covered. Job’s integrity touches his eyes, his business, his household, his generosity, and his heart. This is a man who believes that God’s law applies to every part of life.

At the end Job signs his name. “Here is my signature!” He asks God to answer. And he says, “The words of Job are ended.” He has said everything he has to say. Now he is going to wait for God.

STEP 5

Connection

Job's description of rescuing the poor and clothing himself in righteousness is a picture of the righteous king in Psalm 72:12-14 and Isaiah 11:4-5, and ultimately of Jesus. The "covenant with my eyes" is echoed in Jesus' teaching in Matthew 5:27-30. James 1:27 says that pure religion is "to visit orphans and widows in their affliction."

STEP 6

Application

Look at the list of Job's oath in chapter 31. Choose one area where you want to be more faithful, such as your eyes, your honesty in business, how you treat people who work for you, or how generous you are. Write a one-sentence commitment.

Remember that the deepest loss is losing the sense of God's presence. If you feel that loss, bring it to him honestly.

Ask yourself how you can be "eyes to the blind" to someone this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to search your heart and show you what is not right.
- Thank Jesus for being the righteous one who truly cared for the poor.
- Ask him to help you follow Christ in your relationships.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 12

"Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding."

JOB 28:28

DAY 81 · WEEK 12

Job 32:1-34:37

Elihu speaks, a better theology, but still insufficient

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 96 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 32:1-34:37. A new character, Elihu, enters the book. Read his speeches carefully and ask yourself two questions: what does he get right, and where does he go wrong?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Job's friends have stopped speaking, because "he was righteous in his own eyes" (32:1). Then a young man who has been listening, Elihu, speaks up. He has waited because the others were older, but he has grown angry at both sides: at Job for justifying himself rather than God, and at the three friends for failing to answer. Elihu is not mentioned in the prologue or in God's closing words, and scholars have long debated what to make of him. He says some true and fine things, and he also makes errors. Read him critically.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Elihu is the son of Barachel the Buzite, and he is angry with Job "because he justified himself rather than God" (32:2).
2. He says that he waited because the others were older: "I am young in years, and you are aged; therefore I was timid" (32:6).
3. "It is not the old who are wise, nor the aged who understand what is right" (32:9).
4. "The Spirit of God has made me, and the breath of the Almighty gives me life" (33:4).
5. He says, "God speaks in one way, and in two, though man does not perceive it" (33:14), including in dreams and in pain.
6. "If there be for him an angel, a mediator, one of the thousand, to declare to man what is right for him, and he is merciful to him, and says, Deliver him from going down into the

pit, I have found a ransom" (33:23-24).

7. "Far be it from God that he should do wickedness, and from the Almighty that he should do wrong" (34:10).

8. He says, "Job speaks without knowledge; his words are without insight" (34:35), and that Job "adds rebellion to his sin" (34:37).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Elihu is a puzzling figure. He is the only one of Job's four counselors who is not rebuked in the epilogue, but he is also never praised. He speaks for six chapters, and then he vanishes. Most readers have found something to admire and something to be wary of in him.

What he gets right is worth noting. He is right that God speaks to people through many means, including suffering. He is right that God is just. He is right that human beings cannot stand on their own righteousness. His speech about the "mediator" and the "ransom" in 33:23-24 is a high point. It echoes the language that Job himself used in 9:33 and 16:19, and it lifts the idea that there is a way for a sinner to be delivered. Some of what he says points in a direction that will be fulfilled in the gospel.

But he also makes a mistake that is perhaps more subtle than the friends'. He sees suffering mainly as discipline. For Elihu, pain is God's way of warning a person who is heading for the pit. This is sometimes true, but he applies it to Job, whose pain was never meant as a correction. He tells Job that he is adding rebellion to sin, which is a harsh charge for a man who is not guilty of the original sin.

Elihu also speaks with unusual confidence for a young man. "One who is perfect in knowledge is with you" (36:4). He is certain that he has the answer. His speeches are full of "I will" and "I will declare." There is a pride in him that the rest of the book will not let stand.

His speeches serve a purpose in the book. They bring together the best of what the friends said and push it toward the speech of God. They show how close a person can come to the truth and still miss the point. Then God speaks, and everything changes.

STEP 5

Connection

The "mediator" and the "ransom" of 33:23-24 point to Christ, who "gave himself as a ransom for all" (1 Timothy 2:5-6) and to whom "the Spirit" bears witness (John 15:26). Hebrews 12:5-11 develops the idea of suffering as discipline for God's children. 1 Corinthians 8:1 warns that "knowledge puffs up, but love builds up."

STEP 6

Application

Think about how you respond to a person who is a good deal younger or older than you. Do you listen well?

When you give advice, test it on yourself. Would you want someone to say this to you if you were in the same pain?

Notice the “mediator” in verses 23 and 24, and spend a few minutes thanking Jesus for being the one who found the ransom.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the different ways he speaks to you.
- Ask him to keep you listening, not only certain.
- Ask him to make you humble with those who suffer.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 12

“Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding.”

JOB 28:28

DAY 82 · WEEK 12

Job 35:1-37:24

Elihu's case for God's majesty, the storm approaches

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 35:1-37:24. Elihu continues with three more speeches. They get steadily more poetic, ending with a long description of a storm. Read chapter 37 as if you are watching a storm roll in, because the next chapter is the answer from the storm.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Elihu's last three speeches are the finest in his section. He starts with a charge that Job is claiming too much, but the speeches build toward a description of God's majesty in nature. By the end, the sky is darkening and the thunder is rolling. There is a sense of something about to happen. In the next chapter, God will speak, and he will speak from the whirlwind.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Elihu asks, "If you have sinned, what do you accomplish against him?" (35:6).
2. He says that people cry out under oppression but do not ask, "Where is God my Maker, who gives songs in the night?" (35:10).
3. "Behold, God is mighty, and does not despise any; he is mighty in strength of understanding" (36:5).
4. "He delivers the afflicted by their affliction and opens their ear by oppression" (36:15).
5. "Behold, God is great, and we know him not; the number of his years is unsearchable" (36:26).
6. He describes rain, thunder, and lightning as the work of God (36:27-33).
7. "God thunders wondrously with his voice; he does great things that we cannot comprehend" (37:5).

8. He tells Job: “Stop and consider the wondrous works of God” (37:14).
9. The final line: “The Almighty, we cannot find him; he is great in power; justice and abundant righteousness he will not violate. Therefore men fear him; he does not regard any who are wise in their own conceit” (37:23-24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Elihu’s best contribution is his emphasis on God as Maker. In 35:10 he asks a beautiful question: “Where is God my Maker, who gives songs in the night?” It points to something Job and his friends have all but forgotten: God is not only a judge. He is the one who gives songs in the dark. The God who allows the night is also the God who sings in it.

His description in chapter 36 of how God uses affliction deserves attention. “He delivers the afflicted by their affliction.” This is a rich line. God uses suffering to open ears, to teach people, and to bring them to himself. It is a true principle, and many believers can testify that they heard God most clearly in their pain. But Elihu is wrong if he thinks that this is the only reason suffering happens. In Job’s case, the real reason is not that.

The speech ends with weather. The thunderstorm in chapter 37 is a piece of poetry. Elihu says that God sends the snow and the rain, that he controls the clouds, and that no one can comprehend how it all works. “Do you know how God lays his command upon them?” (37:15). It is a series of questions, and it prepares for the greater questions to come. In a way, Elihu has started to do what God will do: use creation to remind a human being how small he is.

The last verse is a good summary. “He does not regard any who are wise in their own conceit.” It is a warning to Job and to Elihu himself. Elihu is also wise in his own conceit, as the book is about to reveal. All the human voices have spoken, and none of them has understood. Now there is silence, and then the storm.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 42:8 says, “By day the LORD commands his steadfast love, and at night his song is with me.” Paul and Silas sang hymns in prison at midnight (Acts 16:25). Psalm 29 praises the voice of the LORD in the thunder. Jesus calmed a storm and made the disciples ask, “Who then is this?” (Mark 4:41).

STEP 6

Application

Pay attention to the weather this week. When there is a storm, watch it and pray Psalm 29. Let it remind you that you are small and God is great.

Ask God to give you a song in the night. If you are in a dark season, tell him that you are waiting for the song.

Be wary of any belief that explains everything about suffering. God is great, and we know him not.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for his greatness, in your own words.

Thank him for songs in the night.

Ask him to keep you from being wise in your own eyes.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 12

"Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding."

JOB 28:28

DAY 83 · WEEK 12

Job 38:1-39:30

God speaks from the whirlwind, "Where were you?"

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 38:1-39:30. Slow down. God has not spoken in the book since the prologue. Read his questions aloud and try to answer them honestly. You will find that you cannot.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After thirty-seven chapters of human speeches, God answers. He comes in a storm, the sort of storm Elihu was describing at the end of his speech. He does not explain Job's suffering. He does not mention the court scene in heaven, or Satan, or the test. He does not defend himself or scold Job. He asks Job a series of questions about the world he has made, and the questions are so large that Job's own question seems to shrink. This is the turning point of the book.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Then the LORD answered Job out of the whirlwind" (38:1).
2. "Who is this that darkens counsel by words without knowledge?" (38:2).
3. "Dress for action like a man; I will question you, and you make it known to me" (38:3).
4. "Where were you when I laid the foundation of the earth? Tell me, if you have understanding" (38:4).
5. "When the morning stars sang together and all the sons of God shouted for joy" (38:7).
6. God shut the sea behind doors and said, "Thus far shall you come, and no farther, and here shall your proud waves be stayed" (38:8-11).
7. "Have you entered into the springs of the sea...Have the gates of death been revealed to you?" (38:16-17).

8. God asks about light, snow, hail, rain, the constellations, and the clouds (38:19-38).
9. “Who provides for the raven its prey, when its young ones cry to God for help?” (38:41).
10. Chapter 39 moves through wild animals: the mountain goat, the wild donkey, the wild ox, the ostrich, the war horse, the hawk, and the eagle.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to notice is what God does not say. He gives no reason for Job’s suffering. If Job had wanted a theological explanation, he does not receive one. Some readers are disappointed. But think about what has happened. Job has been asking for an audience with God for thirty chapters. Now he has it. And what he receives is not an argument. It is a presence.

The second thing is that God’s questions are pitched at the right size. Job has been treating the world as if it should make sense to him, as if God owed him an account. The questions say: do you know how the world works? Where were you when it began? Do you know how to feed the lion, or when the mountain goats give birth? The point is not to humiliate Job. It is to show him that he is in the middle of a world far larger and wiser than he can see. If he cannot understand the sea, how can he understand the plan of God?

Pay attention to the tenderness behind the questions. The sea is shut in with doors, like a newborn wrapped in swaddling clothes (38:9). The morning stars sing at creation. The raven’s young cry out, and God provides. The wild donkey is given the wilderness as a home, and the ostrich is allowed to be foolish, because he made her that way. This is not a cold, mechanical universe. It is full of joy and wildness and care. It is the work of a God who delights in what he has made.

This is, in a way, the answer to Job’s question. Job wanted to know whether God is just. God’s answer is to show him God’s wisdom and God’s care in a thousand other places, and to invite Job to trust that this wisdom extends to the part of the world he cannot understand: his own suffering.

The answer to suffering is not an explanation. It is the character of the one who rules.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 104 is a hymn that follows the same path as God’s speech. Jesus used the birds and flowers to say that the Father cares for his children: “Look at the birds of the air…your heavenly Father feeds them” (Matthew 6:26). Colossians 1:16-17 says that all things were created through the Son, and in him all things hold together.

STEP 6

Application

Go outside and spend ten minutes looking carefully at something God made: an insect, a tree, a cloud. Ask God to teach you something about himself from it.

When you are tempted to demand that God explain himself, return to chapter 38 and answer the questions honestly.

Pray that you would trust God's character even when you cannot see his plan.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for something he has made that you did not.
- Tell him that you are small and that you trust him because of who he is.
- Ask him to help you delight in what he has made.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 12

"Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding."

JOB 28:28

DAY 84 · WEEK 12

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Job 28:28 several times, and then try to say it without looking. Read the meditation and the week in review, and then choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or discuss with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding."

JOB 28:28

REST

Meditation

Job 28:28 is the answer to a question that the whole poem has been asking: where can wisdom be found? After describing all the things human beings can discover, the poem gives a single, simple verse.

"The fear of the Lord, that is wisdom." The word "fear" does not mean terror. It means reverence, awe, and a settled sense that God is God and you are not. It is the posture of a creature before the Creator. To fear the Lord is to take him seriously, to take his words seriously, and to let him be the final authority in your life. It is the starting point of all true knowledge.

"And to turn away from evil is understanding." Here wisdom becomes practical. Understanding is not first about having correct information. It is about the direction of your life. It is a turning. The wise person is not the one who has solved every puzzle but the one who walks away from what is wrong, even when it is costly.

Notice that neither half of the verse claims to explain suffering. This is the wisdom Job needs. He cannot solve the puzzle. But he can fear God and turn from evil, and that is what the narrator said about him in 1:1. The book keeps coming back to that.

For the Christian, this wisdom has a face. Jesus is the wisdom of God. To fear the Lord is to come to Christ, and to turn from evil is to follow him.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the last of the debates and the beginning of God's answer. You heard Job describe the oppression of the poor and ask why God does not seem to act, and you heard him praise God's power as only the outskirts of his ways. You read the great poem on wisdom in chapter 28 and Job's vow of integrity. You read Job's long final defense, in which he remembered his better days, described his present pain, and swore that he had not wronged anyone. Then Elihu spoke. He said some wise things and made some mistakes, and he ended with a storm. In the last reading of the week, God answered Job out of the whirlwind with questions about the world he has made. The week taught that wisdom begins with the fear of the Lord, and that God answers not with explanations but with his own greatness.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Chapter 28 says that wisdom cannot be bought or mined. Where have you been looking for wisdom? What would it mean for you to begin with the fear of the Lord this week?

How does Jesus, who is the wisdom of God and who came as a man of suffering, show you what the fear of the Lord and turning from evil look like in practice? Think of one scene from the Gospels where you see this clearly.

God answered Job with questions about creation rather than answers about suffering. What question do you most want God to answer? What would it mean to trust him with it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to teach you the fear of the Lord.

Thank him that Jesus is the wisdom of God.

Rest in his greatness this Sabbath.

DAY 85 · WEEK 13

Job 40:1-42:17

Job's response; restoration, the answer is a person

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 40:1-42:17. This is the end of the book. Job answers God, God speaks again, and then there is an epilogue in prose. Pay special attention to Job's confession in 42:1-6, and to what God says about Job and his friends in 42:7-9.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday God began to speak. Today he finishes. Job has been silent through the first round of questions, and now God presses him again. He describes two great creatures, Behemoth and Leviathan, which are beyond Job's power to control. Then Job speaks for the last time, and the book moves into its quiet ending. In the prologue you were allowed to see what Job could not. In the epilogue Job sees something that you cannot see unless you have been through what he has: God himself.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God asks, "Shall a faultfinder contend with the Almighty?" (40:2). Job answers, "Behold, I am of small account; what shall I answer you? I lay my hand on my mouth" (40:4).
2. God speaks again and asks, "Will you even put me in the wrong? Will you condemn me that you may be in the right?" (40:8).
3. Behemoth is described as "the first of the works of God" (40:19), strong enough to be calm when the river rages.
4. Leviathan is a creature no one can capture or tame. God says, "Who then is he who can stand before me?" (41:10) and calls him "king over all the sons of pride" (41:34).
5. Job answers, "I know that you can do all things, and that no purpose of yours can be thwarted" (42:2).

6. He admits that he spoke of things beyond him: “Things too wonderful for me, which I did not know” (42:3).
7. “I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you; therefore I despise myself, and repent in dust and ashes” (42:5-6).
8. God tells Eliphaz, “My anger burns against you and against your two friends, for you have not spoken of me what is right, as my servant Job has” (42:7).
9. Job prays for his friends, and the LORD restores his fortunes and gives him twice as much as he had before (42:8-10).
10. Job has seven sons and three daughters again, and he lives 140 years, “old and full of days” (42:13-17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The final answer of the book is not an argument. It is an encounter. Job says it directly: “I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you.” Before, Job had a faith made of reports and reasoning. He knew the right things about God. Now he has seen him. The suffering did not give Job a reason. It gave him God. That is not a consolation prize. It is the greatest thing that a person can receive.

His repentance needs careful reading. He does not repent of the sins his friends accused him of, because those were false. He repents of speaking about things he did not understand, of treating God as a defendant in his case. “I despise myself” might also be translated “I retract” or “I submit.” He sees how small he is, and how much he had assumed. This is not groveling. It is the right posture of a creature who has seen the Creator.

The surprise in 42:7 is that God vindicates Job over his friends. “You have not spoken of me what is right, as my servant Job has.” How could this be, when Job said such bold and bitter things? The answer seems to be that Job spoke to God, honestly, while the friends spoke about God, dishonestly. They defended him with false claims. Job wrestled with him with true ones. God prefers honest wrestling to false piety.

Notice the next detail. Job prays for the friends who hurt him. The restoration comes after that prayer. The man who longed for a mediator now becomes one. It is a small picture of what Christ will do on a larger scale.

The restoration is real, but it is not the point. The children who died are not replaced, and the new ones are not substitutes for the old. The book does not say that suffering always ends in earthly blessing. But it does say that God is faithful, and that his last word is never the grave.

STEP 5

Connection

James 5:11 says, “You have heard of the steadfastness of Job, and you have seen the purpose of the Lord, how the Lord is compassionate and merciful.” Isaiah 6:5 records a similar response from Isaiah, who sees the Lord and says, “Woe is me!” Paul prays that we might know Christ and the power of his resurrection (Philippians 3:10). Jesus prays for those who persecute him (Luke 23:34).

STEP 6

Application

Think about the difference between knowing about God and knowing him. Which describes you more? Ask God to give you the second.

If someone has wronged you, pray for them this week by name. It may be hard. Do it anyway.

Also, remember that God prefers honest prayer to polite prayer. If you have been holding back what you actually think, tell him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you want to see him and not only hear of him.
- Confess any place where you have spoken of what you do not understand.
- Ask him to teach you to pray for those who have hurt you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 13

“I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you.”

JOB 42:5

DAY 86 · WEEK 13

Ephesians 1:11; Romans 11:33-36; Job 42:1-6

The Decrees of God and Providence

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ephesians 1:11, Romans 11:33-36, and Job 42:1-6. Read all three as a single statement about God's purposes: that he works all things according to his will, that his ways are beyond tracing out, and that Job's answer to such a God is to say, "I know that you can do all things."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

You have just finished the book of Job, and now you pause. This is a doctrinal day, a chance to step back from the story and think about what the Bible teaches about God's rule over the world. Job's book raises a question that every believer eventually faces: if God is in control, why does he allow evil and suffering? You will not find a full answer here. But the Bible teaches clearly that God is sovereign, that he is good, and that he is not the author of sin. Learning to hold these truths together is part of growing up in the faith.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Ephesians 1:11 says that God "works all things according to the counsel of his will." The word "all" is the key.
2. The context is salvation. We "have obtained an inheritance, having been predestined according to the purpose of him who works all things" (Ephesians 1:11).
3. Romans 11:33 cries out, "Oh, the depth of the riches and wisdom and knowledge of God! How unsearchable are his judgments and how inscrutable his ways!"
4. Paul asks, "Who has known the mind of the Lord, or who has been his counselor?" (Romans 11:34). He is quoting Isaiah 40:13, and the next verse echoes Job 41:11.

5. “For from him and through him and to him are all things. To him be glory forever. Amen” (Romans 11:36).
6. In Job 42:2, Job says, “I know that you can do all things, and that no purpose of yours can be thwarted.”
7. In Job 42:3, he admits, “I have uttered what I did not understand, things too wonderful for me, which I did not know.”
8. Job 42:5-6 describes his new sight and his repentance.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Christian church has long taught that God has a plan for the world and carries it out. Theologians call the plan God’s decree and the carrying out of it providence. The Westminster Confession puts it this way: God, “from all eternity, did by the most wise and holy counsel of his own will, freely and unchangeably ordain whatsoever comes to pass.” It then adds three careful clarifications. God is not the author of sin. No violence is done to the will of creatures. And the freedom and responsibility of secondary causes are not removed but established.

Providence has three parts. First, God preserves his creation. “In him all things hold together” (Colossians 1:17). If God stopped sustaining the world for a moment, it would cease to exist. Second, God concurs with the actions of his creatures. Everything that happens involves real creatures acting, and God’s rule is in and through them. Third, God governs, directing everything toward his purposes.

The book of Job shows all of this at work. Look at chapter 1. The Sabeans raid, fire falls from heaven, the Chaldeans attack, a great wind strikes the house. Each of these is a real event with real agents, and Satan stands behind them, permitted but limited. And yet Job says, “The LORD has taken away.” That is not because Job is confused. It is because he sees that God is above the causes. He is the first cause, and the others are secondary. The same event can be the sin of the Sabeans and the permission of God. Genesis 50:20 says it clearly in Joseph’s words: “You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good.” The cross is the supreme example: “This Jesus, delivered up according to the definite plan and foreknowledge of God, you crucified and killed by the hands of lawless men” (Acts 2:23). God’s plan and human guilt are both real.

How should we hold these together? We should not claim to understand more than the Bible says. Paul does not try to resolve it. He says, “Oh, the depth!” The right response to this doctrine is worship. And it is a comfort. If God rules everything, then nothing in your life is

outside his hand, and nothing is wasted. The Heidelberg Catechism says that all things come to us "not by chance but from his fatherly hand."

There is a caution, too. This doctrine is meant to comfort sufferers, not to be used on them. The friends of Job tried to explain suffering with theology, and God rebuked them. Speak about providence to yourself in your own pain, and to others only with great gentleness.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Job's final answer in 42:2 is a confession of the doctrine we have been discussing. "I know that you can do all things, and that no purpose of yours can be thwarted." It is not the cry of someone who has found a satisfying argument. It is the settled conviction of someone who has been brought low and has seen God.

What makes it remarkable is when Job says it. He says it without having received an explanation. He still does not know about the courtroom scene in heaven. He still does not know why his children died. But he has seen enough of God to know that God's plan will stand. And that is enough.

This is also how Paul speaks in Romans 11. He has just spent three chapters wrestling with how God will bring about the salvation of Israel and the nations. When he reaches the end, he does not offer a final theory. He breaks into praise. The plan is too deep. "To him be glory forever." The doctrine of providence is not meant to end in a diagram. It is meant to end in a doxology.

The lines in Ephesians 1:11 should be read in context. Paul says that God works all things according to the counsel of his will in order to say something about the security of believers. We have an inheritance. We were chosen. God is working, and he will finish what he started. Providence, in the Bible, is mostly a message of hope for the people of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Proverbs 16:9 says, "The heart of man plans his way, but the LORD establishes his steps." Psalm 115:3 says, "Our God is in the heavens; he does all that he pleases." Jesus said that not even a sparrow falls to the ground apart from the Father (Matthew 10:29). Isaiah 46:9-10 declares, "My counsel shall stand, and I will accomplish all my purpose."

STEP 6

Application

First, take a hard thing in your life and ask, "What does it mean that God is sovereign over this?" Write one sentence and one prayer.

Second, notice the difference between the doctrine as a comfort and the doctrine as a weapon. Resolve to use it only for the first.

Third, spend time in worship. Read Romans 11:33-36 aloud as a prayer, and let it end in praise.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that nothing in your life is outside his hand.
- Tell him about a part of his ways you do not understand, and ask him for trust.
- Give him the glory he is owed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 13

"I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you."

JOB 42:5

DAY 87 · WEEK 13

Romans 8:18-30; 1 Peter 4:12-19; 2 Corinthians 4:7-18

Suffering and the Christian Life

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 8:18-30, 1 Peter 4:12-19, and 2 Corinthians 4:7-18. These three passages are the New Testament's most direct teaching on suffering in the Christian life. Read them side by side, and notice what each says about the purpose, the presence, and the end of suffering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday you thought about God's sovereignty. Today you think about how Christians are to live under it. The book of Job asked why the righteous suffer, and the answer it gave was God himself. The New Testament adds the missing piece: the answer is the God who has suffered. Paul, Peter, and the others wrote as people who were being beaten, jailed, and persecuted. They are not theorizing. They are speaking from inside the experience.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Paul says, "I consider that the sufferings of this present time are not worth comparing with the glory that is to be revealed to us" (Romans 8:18).
2. The whole creation "waits with eager longing" and "groans together in the pains of childbirth" (8:19-22).
3. We "who have the firstfruits of the Spirit, groan inwardly as we wait eagerly for adoption as sons" (8:23).
4. "The Spirit helps us in our weakness…intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words" (8:26).

5. “For those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose” (8:28). The good is defined in verse 29: being “conformed to the image of his Son.”

6. Peter says, “Do not be surprised at the fiery trial when it comes upon you to test you, as though something strange were happening to you” (1 Peter 4:12).

7. “But rejoice insofar as you share Christ’s sufferings, that you may also rejoice and be glad when his glory is revealed” (4:13).

8. “Therefore let those who suffer according to God’s will entrust their souls to a faithful Creator while doing good” (4:19).

9. Paul says, “We have this treasure in jars of clay, to show that the surpassing power belongs to God and not to us” (2 Corinthians 4:7).

10. “For this light momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison” (4:17).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Christian view of suffering differs from every other view in one important way: it centers on a suffering Savior. Other religions explain suffering as illusion, as karma, or as a mere fact of life. The Bible treats suffering as real, as an enemy, as part of a fallen world, and as something God himself has entered. Jesus “learned obedience through what he suffered” (Hebrews 5:8), and he is “a man of sorrows and acquainted with grief” (Isaiah 53:3). When you suffer, you are not alone.

The New Testament gives several reasons for the suffering of Christians, and it is important to keep them together. First, we suffer because of union with Christ. Paul says we are “fellow heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with him in order that we may also be glorified with him” (Romans 8:17). To belong to Jesus is to share his path, which goes through the cross to glory. Second, suffering refines us. It produces endurance, character, and hope (Romans 5:3-5), and it is the means by which God conforms us to his Son (Romans 8:29). Third, suffering is a witness. Paul carries “the death of Jesus” in his body “so that the life of Jesus may also be manifested in our bodies” (2 Corinthians 4:10). Fourth, suffering is the groaning of a creation that is still waiting for its redemption. We live in the time between the first coming and the second, and all of creation feels it.

We must be careful not to turn any of these reasons into a rule that explains every case. This is exactly what Job’s friends did. Jesus said that a man’s blindness was not caused by his sin or his parents’ (John 9:3). Sometimes we simply do not know why. What we do know is that

God has promised never to leave us, that he is working through everything for our good, and that suffering will end.

That promise is the content of Romans 8:28. It is often quoted as if it said that everything that happens is good. It does not. It says that God works all things together for good, and the good is defined: becoming like Christ and sharing in his glory. That is a much deeper kind of good than comfort. And the verses that follow seal it. Nothing can separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus (Romans 8:38-39).

The final piece is hope. Paul calls the affliction "light" and "momentary," not because it is trivial but because he is weighing it against "an eternal weight of glory." The scales are not even. The Christian does not deny the pain. He sets it against what is coming.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Each of the three passages tells you something different. In Romans 8, Paul puts our pain in a cosmic frame. It is part of a creation that groans and a Spirit that groans with us. He does not say that the pain is good. He says that it is not the end. The Spirit helps us pray when we have no words, and that is a mercy that Job did not have.

In 1 Peter, the stress is on not being surprised. Peter writes to believers who are facing persecution, and he tells them that this is normal. "Do not be surprised." Many people come to faith expecting an easier life, and they are shaken when trouble comes. Peter says to expect the fiery trial, and to rejoice when you share Christ's sufferings. He also gives a simple instruction for the sufferer: "entrust your soul to a faithful Creator while doing good" (4:19). The phrase "faithful Creator" answers God's speeches in Job. The one who made the world is the one to trust with your soul.

In 2 Corinthians 4, Paul describes himself as a jar of clay. The treasure is the gospel, and the jar is his fragile, breakable body. The weakness is not a flaw in the plan. It is the plan, so that the power will clearly be God's. He says that he is afflicted but not crushed, perplexed but not driven to despair, struck down but not destroyed (4:8-9). Each of the pairs is a picture of someone near the edge who is held.

Together the passages give a full portrait. Suffering is real and costly. It is not a sign that God has left us. It is used by God for good. It is temporary. And it is shared with Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Job's story points forward to these New Testament passages. Where Job asked for a mediator, Paul says the Spirit intercedes for us. Where Job looked for a redeemer, Peter points to the faithful Creator who is also our Savior. Hebrews 12:1-3 tells us to look to Jesus, who endured the cross. James 1:2-4 and Revelation 21:4 complete the picture: trials now, and no more tears then.

STEP 6

Application

First, if you are suffering now, read Romans 8:18-30 slowly and ask God to help you hear it as a word to you. Identify one phrase that gives you hope.

Second, if you are not suffering, take time to pray for someone who is. Read 1 Peter 4 and ask how you can support a persecuted brother or sister.

Third, learn 2 Corinthians 4:16-17 by heart. It will be a help in your own dark days.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that he suffered for you and with you.
- Tell God where you are weak and ask him to show his strength.
- Ask him to fix your eyes on what is unseen.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 13

"I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you."

JOB 42:5

DAY 88 · WEEK 13

Psalm 73

I was nearly slipping; yet I am continually with you

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 73. It is a psalm about a man who nearly lost his faith over the prosperity of the wicked. Read it as a story with a turning point, and find the verse in which everything changes.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 73 is by Asaph, a leader of worship in David's time. It opens the third book of the Psalter, and it is a perfect companion to Job. Both deal with the problem of the prosperity of the wicked and the pain of the righteous. Job came out of the book with a vision of God. Asaph comes out of the psalm with the same thing, and he tells you exactly where it happened.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Truly God is good to Israel, to those who are pure in heart" (v. 1). This is Asaph's starting point.
2. "But as for me, my feet had almost stumbled, my steps had nearly slipped" (v. 2).
3. The reason: "For I was envious of the arrogant when I saw the prosperity of the wicked" (v. 3).
4. The wicked have no pangs until death, and they are not in trouble as others are (vv. 4-5).
5. They speak with malice and set their mouths against the heavens (vv. 8-9). "They say, How can God know? Is there knowledge in the Most High?" (v. 11).
6. Asaph says, "All in vain have I kept my heart clean and washed my hands in innocence" (v. 13).

7. “But when I thought how to understand this, it seemed to me a wearisome task, until I went into the sanctuary of God; then I discerned their end” (vv. 16-17).
8. The wicked are on “slippery places” and are destroyed in a moment (vv. 18-19).
9. “Whom have I in heaven but you? And there is nothing on earth that I desire besides you” (v. 25).
10. “My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever” (v. 26).
11. “But for me it is good to be near God” (v. 28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The honest first confession of the psalm is worth noticing. Asaph says that he almost fell. He nearly gave up. The reason was not an intellectual doubt but an emotional one: envy. He looked at people who ignored God and seemed to be doing fine, and he felt that his own faithfulness had been a waste. Most believers have felt this.

He describes the wicked in detail. They are fat, free from pain, proud, and violent. They scoff at God. Their prosperity seems to say that there is no judgment. It is a convincing picture, and Asaph does not pretend that it is not.

Then comes verse 16. He tried to think his way through it, and it was “wearisome.” He could not reason it out. The turning point is in verse 17: “until I went into the sanctuary of God.” Something happened in God’s presence that thinking alone could not do. He saw things from the perspective of eternity. “Then I discerned their end.” The picture that looked so solid was a house on slippery ground.

The sanctuary is the place where God is worshiped, and it is where the truth about the world comes back into view. If your perspective is bent by what you see, go to where God is. This is why public worship matters.

What follows is one of the great confessions in the Psalter. “Whom have I in heaven but you?” Asaph moves from envy to desire. He no longer wants what the wicked have. He wants God. He even says that his flesh and heart may fail, and God will still be “the strength of my heart and my portion forever.” The word “portion” recalls the way the tribes were given land. His inheritance is God himself. He ends with the line that carries the whole psalm: “for me it is good to be near God.”

This is exactly where Job ended. The answer to the problem of suffering and unfairness is not a theory. It is God.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 37 deals with the same theme, and so does Jeremiah 12:1. Jesus said, “What does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul?” (Mark 8:36). Paul says that his gain is Christ (Philippians 3:7-8). The idea of God as our portion appears in Lamentations 3:24: “The LORD is my portion, says my soul, therefore I will hope in him.”

STEP 6

Application

If you are envious of someone’s success, take your envy to God in worship. Go to a church service or to a quiet place and sit in his presence. Ask him to show you the end.

Pray verses 25 and 26 as your own. Say them aloud, and then ask yourself if they are honestly true. If not, ask God to make them true.

Pay attention this week to what you desire most. Ask God to teach you to want him more than anything else.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess any envy, and tell God where your feet have nearly slipped.
- Ask him to bring you into his presence and show you the truth.
- Tell him what it means that he is your portion.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 13

“I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you.”

JOB 42:5

DAY 89 · WEEK 13

Psalm 88

O LORD, God of my salvation, the darkest lament

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 88. It is the darkest psalm in the Psalter, and it is meant to be. Read it slowly and do not hurry to a happy ending. There is not one. Notice how it begins, and notice what the psalmist keeps doing.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 88 is attributed to Heman the Ezrahite, a wise man mentioned in 1 Kings 4:31. It is the only lament in the Psalter that ends with no note of hope. Other laments move from complaint to trust. This one begins in darkness and ends in darkness. Why would the Bible include a prayer like this? The answer is that God knows some of his people will walk through seasons that feel exactly like it, and he wants them to know that they are allowed to pray in that darkness. Compare it to Job in his worst chapters.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The first line is a statement of faith: “O LORD, God of my salvation” (v. 1).
2. He cries “day and night” before God and asks that his prayer would come before him (vv. 1-2).
3. “My soul is full of troubles, and my life draws near to Sheol” (v. 3). He feels like one who is already dead (vv. 4-5).
4. “You have put me in the depths of the pit, in the regions dark and deep” (v. 6).
5. “Your wrath lies heavy upon me, and you overwhelm me with all your waves” (v. 7).
6. “You have caused my companions to shun me; you have made me a horror to them” (v. 8).

7. “Every day I call upon you, O LORD; I spread out my hands to you” (v. 9).
8. He asks, “Do you work wonders for the dead? Do the departed rise up to praise you?” (v. 10).
9. “But I, O LORD, cry to you; in the morning my prayer comes before you” (v. 13).
10. “O LORD, why do you cast my soul away? Why do you hide your face from me?” (v. 14).
11. The last line is “my companions have become darkness” (v. 18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Start with what the psalm does not have. There is no turn. No “But you.” No vow to praise. No assurance that God has heard. The psalmist ends with the word “darkness.” If you came to this psalm hoping to be cheered up, you will be disappointed.

But look at what the psalm does have. It begins with “O LORD, God of my salvation.” This is the only line in the psalm that points to light, and it comes first. Whatever else is true, the psalmist is still talking to the God who saves. He does not understand how God can be his salvation and feel like his enemy. But he refuses to stop addressing him. And he says, “Every day I call upon you.” He keeps praying. He spreads out his hands. In verse 13, he says that his prayer will come before God “in the morning.” The darkness has not stopped him from praying.

That is the quiet wonder of the psalm. Faith in this psalm is not a feeling of hope. It is the act of continuing to pray when there is no feeling. It is clinging to the one who seems to be against you. The psalm itself is a prayer, and so it is itself the evidence that the psalmist has not let go.

It is also important to see that God’s word includes this prayer. The Bible does not demand that all faith be cheerful. It gives a place for the person who has no light, and it says, in effect, “Here are words you can use.” If you ever find yourself unable to say anything hopeful, this psalm says that you can still say, “LORD, God of my salvation,” and keep praying.

Finally, the psalm points to Christ. The one who, more than any other, was shunned by companions and overwhelmed by waves of wrath is Jesus. On the cross he took the wrath that lay heavy on us, and he went into the darkness so that we could come out of it. Psalm 88 is, in a deeper sense, his prayer.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus' experience of being deserted by his friends (Mark 14:50) and of bearing the wrath of God is a fulfillment of this psalm. Lamentations 3:1-18 is another prayer that ends in the dark, until verse 19 and following. Hebrews 5:7 describes Jesus offering up prayers with loud cries and tears. Romans 8:26 says the Spirit prays for us when we cannot.

STEP 6

Application

If you are in a dark season, pray this psalm. You do not need to add a happy ending. Say "LORD, God of my salvation," and then say whatever is true.

If you know someone who is in a dark season, resist the urge to hand them a quick answer. Sit with them. Sometimes the best thing you can do is to pray Psalm 88 with them.

Thank Jesus for going into the darkness for you, and for the promise that one day there will be no more.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what the dark feels like, without tidying it up.
- Thank Jesus for going into the dark for you.
- Hold in prayer someone you love who is in the dark today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 13

"I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you."

JOB 42:5

DAY 90 · WEEK 13

Psalm 17

Hear a just cause, O LORD, David's appeal to integrity

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 15 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 17. This is a prayer of David, a man who is under attack and is asking God for vindication. Read it with Job in mind, and notice both the confidence of its opening and the hope of its closing line.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 17 is attributed to David, and its tone is similar to some of Job's. Both men appeal to God as a judge, both claim to have been faithful, and both are surrounded by enemies. David's confidence in his integrity may sound proud at first reading. But look at what he is doing: he is not claiming perfection. He is claiming to be on the right side in a particular dispute, and he is bringing the case to God, the only judge who can settle it. The psalm ends with one of the loveliest hopes in the Psalter.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm begins, "Hear a just cause, O LORD; attend to my cry! Give ear to my prayer from lips free of deceit!" (v. 1).
2. "From your presence let my vindication come! Let your eyes behold the right!" (v. 2).
3. "You have tried my heart, you have visited me by night, you have tested me, and you will find nothing; I have purposed that my mouth will not transgress" (v. 3).
4. "Wondrously show your steadfast love, O Savior of those who seek refuge from their adversaries" (v. 7).
5. "Keep me as the apple of your eye; hide me in the shadow of your wings" (v. 8).
6. The enemies surround him. They are like a lion eager to tear (vv. 9-12).

7. “Arise, O LORD! Confront him, subdue him!” (v. 13).
8. The wicked have their reward in this life, with plenty of children and wealth (v. 14).
9. “As for me, I shall behold your face in righteousness; when I awake, I shall be satisfied with beholding your likeness” (v. 15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with the language of a courtroom. David is making a case. “Hear a just cause.” He is not demanding mercy because he is weak. He is claiming that his cause is right. And he does so by saying that God has already examined him and found nothing wrong. “You have tried my heart…and you will find nothing.” This is not a statement that David is sinless. It is a statement that he has not done what his enemies accuse him of. It is also a statement that God is the final judge, and that David is willing to have his heart examined by him.

Job made the same appeal. “Oh, that I had one to hear me! Let the Almighty answer me!” The difference is that David is more confident that God will respond. He also adds a second image, one of intimacy and protection. “Keep me as the apple of your eye; hide me in the shadow of your wings.” The apple of the eye is the pupil, the most sensitive and protected part of the body. The shadow of the wings is a picture of a mother bird covering her young. David asks for two things at once: to be vindicated like a defendant in court, and to be held like a child. The psalm is a mixture of legal and tender language, and so is the gospel.

Verse 14 is worth noticing. The wicked are filled with the things of this life: wealth, children, a full belly. David does not envy them. He simply notes that this is all they have. Their “portion is in this life.” It echoes Psalm 73 and the end of Job.

And then the ending, which is the heart of the psalm. “As for me, I shall behold your face in righteousness.” David does not say that he wants to be wealthy or safe. He wants to see God’s face. He says that when he wakes, probably a reference to waking from death or from the long night of trouble, he will be “satisfied with beholding your likeness.” This is the same longing Job had in 19:26. “In my flesh I shall see God.” It is the hope that the Old Testament believers held onto: to see God.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus speaks of the pure in heart who “shall see God” (Matthew 5:8). Paul says, “Now we see in a mirror dimly, but then face to face” (1 Corinthians 13:12). John writes, “We know that when he appears we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is” (1 John 3:2). Revelation 22:4 says, “They will see his face.” Jesus compared himself to a hen who gathers her chicks under her wings (Matthew 23:37).

STEP 6

Application

Ask God to examine your heart, as David does. Say “You have tried my heart” and then listen. Confess whatever comes to mind, and receive the forgiveness that is yours in Christ.

Ask yourself if you want to see God’s face more than anything else. If not, ask him to put that desire in you.

Take comfort in the picture of the apple of his eye. Say aloud, “I am the apple of his eye.” If that is hard to believe, bring that to him too.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to search your heart and show you what is wrong.
- Ask him to hide you in the shadow of his wings.
- Tell him you long to be satisfied in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 13

“I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you.”

JOB 42:5

DAY 91 · WEEK 13

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Job 42:5 slowly, several times, then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or discuss.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you."

JOB 42:5

REST

Meditation

Job 42:5 is the center of the book of Job. After forty-one chapters of arguing, questioning, suffering, and listening, Job says something quiet.

"I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear." This is how most of us begin. We hear about God from our parents, a preacher, a book, or a friend. We know the facts. We can say the creeds. That is a good beginning, and it is a real knowledge, but it is secondhand. It is a report.

"But now my eye sees you." Something has changed. Job has encountered God. He is no longer relying on what others have said. He has seen the Lord in the whirlwind, heard his voice, and been met by his presence. The word "now" tells you that this is the result of everything that has come before. Suffering, with all its pain, led him here.

This is one of the most hopeful statements in the Bible. It means that the purpose of suffering, in the deepest sense, is not to teach us a lesson or to punish us. It is to bring us to the place where we see God. This does not mean that the suffering is good in itself. It is not. But God can use it to give you a clearer sight of himself than you had before.

For the Christian, the verse is even richer. In Jesus, "we have seen his glory" (John 1:14). He is the one in whom the invisible God has become visible. To see Jesus is to see the Father (John 14:9). Every Christian's journey is from hearing to seeing, and it is finished when we see him face to face.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the book of Job. You read God's answer from the whirlwind and the questions about creation that silenced Job. You read the last chapters, in which God vindicated Job over his friends, Job prayed for them, and the LORD restored his fortunes. You paused for two doctrinal days: on the decrees of God and providence, and on suffering and the Christian life. You saw that God rules over every event, that he is not the author of sin, and that Christians suffer in union with a suffering Savior. You prayed three psalms alongside Job. Psalm 73 showed you the sanctuary as the place where perspective returns. Psalm 88 gave you a prayer for the dark that has no easy ending. Psalm 17 gave you the hope of seeing God's face. The week taught that the answer to suffering is the presence of God.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Job went from hearing about God to seeing him. Where are you on that path? What would it look like for your knowledge of God to become less secondhand?

How does Jesus, the visible image of the invisible God, fulfill what Job longed for? Think about a moment in the Gospels where Jesus shows you what God is like, and what it means that you can see him there.

Of the three psalms you read this week, which one was closest to where you are right now? Write a prayer in your own words that begins with that psalm.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to see him and not only hear of him.

Thank him for Jesus, in whom you see his glory.

Ask him to use suffering to draw you nearer.

DAY 92 · WEEK 14

Psalm 26

Vindicate me, O LORD, for I have walked in my integrity

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 26. It is another prayer of David about integrity. Read it carefully, and watch for the way the confident opening gives way to a request for mercy in the final verses.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the last psalm of the unit, and it fits the theme well. Job swore an oath of integrity in Job 31, and David does something similar here. He asks God to examine him and declares that he has walked faithfully. The question is how a sinful man can say such things. The answer is in the last two verses, where David asks to be redeemed. His integrity is real, but it is not his ground of acceptance. His ground is God's steadfast love.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Vindicate me, O LORD, for I have walked in my integrity, and I have trusted in the LORD without wavering" (v. 1).
2. "Prove me, O LORD, and try me; test my heart and my mind" (v. 2).
3. "For your steadfast love is before my eyes, and I walk in your faithfulness" (v. 3).
4. He does not sit with the worthless or go in with hypocrites (vv. 4-5).
5. "I wash my hands in innocence and go around your altar, O LORD" (v. 6).
6. "O LORD, I love the habitation of your house and the place where your glory dwells" (v. 8).
7. "Do not sweep my soul away with sinners, nor my life with bloodthirsty men" (v. 9).
8. "But as for me, I shall walk in my integrity; redeem me, and be gracious to me" (v. 11).

9 “My foot stands on level ground; in the great assembly I will bless the LORD” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is a psalm that raises a question for many new believers: how can anyone say “I have walked in my integrity”? It sounds like boasting. But there are three things to see.

First, the integrity is about direction, not perfection. David says that he has trusted in the LORD “without wavering.” He is not claiming to have never sinned. He is saying that his life has been oriented toward God, and that he has not given his loyalty to anyone else. The Hebrew word for integrity means wholeness or completeness. It describes a life that is not divided.

Second, the integrity is rooted in God’s love. Look at verse 3: “Your steadfast love is before my eyes.” The reason he walks faithfully is that he has been looking at God’s love. His obedience is a response to grace, not an attempt to earn it.

Third, and most important, the psalm ends with a request for mercy. “Redeem me, and be gracious to me.” David has been describing his faithfulness for ten verses, and then he asks for redemption and grace. These are the words of someone who knows he needs saving. He does not say, “Redeem me because I deserve it.” He says, “Redeem me, and be gracious.” He is trusting in God, not in his own record. The same is true in Job, who is declared righteous by God and yet longs for a Redeemer.

The picture at the end is of firm ground. “My foot stands on level ground.” In a psalm full of danger and temptation, the final image is of a safe place to stand, and a congregation gathered to praise.

This is what the unit has been moving toward. In the face of suffering and injustice, the faithful person says: I will walk in my integrity, and I will trust in God’s grace.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that his own righteousness is “a righteousness not my own, but that which comes through faith in Christ” (Philippians 3:9). In Psalm 130:3-4 the psalmist says, “If you, O LORD, should mark iniquities, O Lord, who could stand? But with you there is forgiveness.” Hebrews 10:22 invites us to draw near “with a true heart in full assurance of faith.”

STEP 6

Application

Pray this psalm as a final prayer for the unit. Ask God to test your heart and mind. Then, like David, say, “Redeem me, and be gracious to me.”

Think about where you have been divided. What would it mean for your life to be more whole this week?

Plan to be in the “great assembly” on Sunday, and sing with the congregation.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to test your heart and mind.
- Admit that you cannot walk in integrity on your own, and ask for his help.
- Bless him for setting your foot on level ground.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 14

“God said to Moses, I AM WHO I AM. And he said, Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you.”

EXODUS 3:14

DAY 93 · WEEK 14

Review and Reflection

Unit 4 review, Job, Suffering & Sovereignty

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For I know that my Redeemer lives, and at the last he will stand upon the earth."
>
> JOB 19:25

REST

Meditation

Job 19:25 is the unit's anchor verse, and it deserves a final look. Read it aloud once more before you go on.

"For I know." This is the language of certainty. Job has been saying "I do not understand" for eighteen chapters. Now he says "I know." The things he does not know are many. What he knows is one thing, and it is enough.

"That my Redeemer lives." The word for "Redeemer" is the family rescuer, the one who steps in when a relative is in trouble. Job does not say that he hopes for one or that he wishes for one. He says that he has one, and that this person is alive. In the middle of death and loss, he points to life.

"And at the last he will stand upon the earth." There will be a final day. The Redeemer will take his place on the earth, as a judge or an advocate in a courtroom. The one who seems to be missing will come. The wrongs will be set right.

Job could not have known how fully this would be fulfilled. In Jesus, the Redeemer has come, lived, died, and risen. He lives, and he will stand upon the earth again. Every Christian can say this verse with more confidence than Job, because we have seen the empty tomb. Keep the verse close. It will carry you through the hardest days.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 4 you have read the book of Job and a series of psalms that go with it. The unit began with a scene that Job himself never saw: the heavenly court, where Satan accused Job of serving God only for the benefits. God allowed Job to be tested, within limits, and Job lost his children, his wealth, and his health. Even so, he worshiped. You prayed Psalms 10 and 13, which gave you words for “Where are you?” and “How long?”

Then the friends came. Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar each spoke three times, and they all said the same thing in different ways: Job must have sinned. They defended God with false claims, and they turned a general truth about wisdom and consequences into a rule that crushed a suffering man. Job answered them with grief and anger and honesty. Through his speeches, a longing grew: for an arbiter, for a witness in heaven, and for a Redeemer who lives. In chapter 19 he said the words that anchor this unit.

You read Psalm 22, the great psalm of the forsaken and the vindicated, and saw how Jesus prayed it on the cross. In the later chapters, Job insisted on his integrity, praised God’s power as only the outskirts of his ways, and heard the poem on wisdom that ends with the fear of the Lord. Elihu spoke last among the humans, and he said some wise things and some mistaken ones.

Then God answered from the whirlwind. He did not explain, but asked questions about the world he had made. Job saw him, repented of his presumption, and prayed for his friends. God vindicated Job and restored him. In two doctrinal pauses, you studied God’s providence and the Christian’s suffering. In Psalms 73, 88, 17, and 26, you found a sanctuary where the truth comes back into focus, a prayer for the darkest night, the hope of seeing God’s face, and a plea for redemption.

The unit taught that suffering is not a verdict, that God is sovereign and good, and that the answer to suffering is not an explanation but a Person.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does the prologue of Job reveal about the nature of suffering and Satan’s role?

Look back at chapters 1 and 2. Satan can act only with God’s permission, and every time the permission has a limit. Job’s suffering was not punishment, and he never learned the reason. What does this teach you about how to think about suffering in your own life? How does it help you to know that Satan is on a leash?

Where do Job's friends go wrong in their theology of suffering?

The friends held a general truth, that sin has consequences, and turned it into a rule that explained everything. Recall how they treated Job, and how God responded in 42:7. What lessons about comforting people and handling Scripture do you take from their mistakes? Is there a place where you are tempted to do what they did?

How does God's answer from the whirlwind address Job's questions?

God did not give Job an explanation. He asked questions about creation, and showed Job his own wisdom and care. Job's response was, "Now my eye sees you." Why was that enough? Write a few sentences about what it means that the answer to suffering is God himself.

How does Job's story point forward to Christ, the truly righteous one who suffered?

Think about Job's longing for a mediator, a witness, and a Redeemer, and about Psalm 22. Jesus is the righteous one who suffered unjustly, the mediator who stands between God and us, and the Redeemer who lives. Write a short prayer of thanks to him for each of these roles.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that suffering is never a sign he has left you.

Ask him to help you trust him when you do not understand.

Ask him to prepare you for what comes next.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 5 · DAYS 94-116

The Mosaic Covenant I: Exodus

Exodus 1-24

God redeems before he commands. The pattern of grace establishing law.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery."

EXODUS 20:2

Psalms 106, 77, 114, and 105:26-45 retell the exodus as worship.

UNIT 5

In this unit

WEEK 14

94	Exodus 1:1-2:25	*Reading*
95	Exodus 3:1-4:31	*Reading*
96	Exodus 3:13-15; Exodus 34:5-7	*Doctrine*
97	Psalm 106:1-23	*Psalm*
98	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 15

99	Exodus 5:1-7:25	*Reading*
100	Exodus 8:1-9:35	*Reading*
101	Exodus 10:1-11:10	*Reading*
102	Exodus 12:1-13:16	*Reading*
103	Exodus 13:17-14:31	*Reading*
104	Psalm 106:24-48	*Psalm*
105	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 16

106	Exodus 15:1-27	*Reading*
107	Psalm 77	*Psalm*
108	Psalm 114	*Psalm*
109	Exodus 16:1-18:27	*Reading*
110	Exodus 19:1-20:26	*Reading*
111	Exodus 20:1-17; Matthew 5:17-48; Romans 13:8-10	*Doctrine*
112	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 17

113	Exodus 21:1-22:31	*Reading*
114	Exodus 23:1-24:18	*Reading*
115	Psalm 105:26-45	*Psalm*

DAY 94 · WEEK 14

Exodus 1:1-2:25

Israel enslaved; Moses born, hidden, and called

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 1:1-2:25. Four hundred years pass between the end of Genesis and the opening of Exodus, and the chapters you are reading cover the start of Israel's slavery and the birth of its deliverer. Read the story with the Genesis promises in mind, and notice how often God works through small, hidden acts of courage.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Genesis ended with Joseph's family safe in Egypt. Exodus begins with a sentence that sounds like a continuation: "These are the names of the sons of Israel." But the world has changed. Joseph's generation has died, and the descendants of Jacob have become a great nation within Egypt's borders. That is the fulfillment of God's promise to Abraham to make him a great nation (Genesis 12:2). It is also the cause of Egypt's fear. The book of Exodus is the second book of the Law, and it tells how God turned a family of slaves into a covenant people. Everything in the Bible that speaks of redemption looks back to what happens here.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The people of Israel are "fruitful and increased greatly; they multiplied and grew exceedingly strong, so that the land was filled with them" (1:7). This echoes the creation command in Genesis 1:28.
2. "Now there arose a new king over Egypt, who did not know Joseph" (1:8). He fears that Israel will join Egypt's enemies and enslaves them (1:9-11).
3. The more they were oppressed, "the more they multiplied and the more they spread abroad" (1:12).

4. The midwives Shiphrah and Puah "feared God" and did not obey Pharaoh's order to kill the Hebrew boys (1:17).
5. God "dealt well with the midwives" (1:20), and Pharaoh then commands that every newborn Hebrew boy be thrown into the Nile (1:22).
6. A Levite woman hides her baby son for three months, and then puts him in a basket among the reeds (2:1-3). The word for "basket" is the same word used for Noah's ark.
7. Pharaoh's daughter finds him, takes pity, and names him Moses, "because I drew him out of the water" (2:10). His sister Miriam arranges for his own mother to nurse him (2:7-9).
8. Moses, as an adult, kills an Egyptian who is beating a Hebrew, and flees to Midian when it becomes known (2:11-15).
9. In Midian, he marries Zipporah and has a son named Gershom, "I have been a sojourner in a foreign land" (2:21-22).
10. "God heard their groaning, and God remembered his covenant with Abraham, with Isaac, and with Jacob. God saw the people of Israel, and God knew" (2:24-25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening chapters of Exodus are told in a quiet way. God is not named as acting until the last verses of chapter 2. Until then, the story is carried by people: a frightened king, two midwives, a mother and a sister, and a princess. The reader is invited to see how God's purposes move forward even when he seems to be absent. It is a pattern you have seen before, in Joseph's story, and in Job's.

Pharaoh is a portrait of power that fears. He has the largest empire in the world, and he is afraid of a population of slaves. His answer is violence, first by labor and then by murder. But every plan he makes fails. The more he oppresses, the more Israel grows. The Nile that he orders the babies thrown into becomes the place where a rescuer is drawn out. The book is teaching you early that God's promises cannot be defeated by the schemes of rulers.

The midwives are among the quiet heroes of Scripture. They "feared God" more than they feared Pharaoh. The fear of God, as you learned in Job 28:28, is the beginning of wisdom, and it is also the source of courage. They have no power, and they do something small: they let the boys live. God honors them and gives them families of their own. Their story is a reminder that obedience to God sometimes means quiet resistance to unjust authority.

Moses' own story is full of echoes. A baby is put in a floating basket, the same word as Noah's ark, and is saved through water. He is raised in the house of the oppressor, and he is then a fugitive. At first he tries to rescue his people by his own strength, with violence, and it fails. He needs to be taught a better way. Forty years in the wilderness will do that.

But the center of the passage is the last two verses. God hears, remembers, sees, and knows. These are four verbs, and the first three recall what God does in covenant. "Remembered his covenant" does not mean that God had forgotten. It means that he is now acting on what he promised. The slavery of Israel has not made God forget Abraham. It has set the stage for him to keep his word.

STEP 5

Connection

Stephen retells this story in Acts 7:17-29, and Hebrews 11:23-27 praises the faith of Moses' parents and of Moses himself. Matthew presents the infant Jesus escaping Herod's murder of the boys in a way that echoes this chapter (Matthew 2:13-18). Paul says that God "chose what is weak in the world to shame the strong" (1 Corinthians 1:27), and Moses is an early example.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a place where you feel powerless. Remember the midwives. A small act of faithfulness is not wasted.

Notice how often God's actions in this story are hidden. If you are in a season where you cannot see God working, ask him to show you where he is, and trust that he has heard.

Pray for people who are living under oppression today, and ask what you could do to help.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he hears groaning and remembers his covenant.
- Ask for courage to fear him more than anyone with power.
- Pray for someone who is crying out today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 14

“God said to Moses, I AM WHO I AM. And he said, Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you.”

EXODUS 3:14

DAY 95 · WEEK 14

Exodus 3:1-4:31

The burning bush; the divine name I AM; Moses commissioned

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 3:1-4:31. This is the call of Moses. Read it slowly. Pay special attention to what God says about himself, and to each excuse that Moses offers and how God answers it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Forty years have passed since Moses fled Egypt. He is now eighty, a shepherd in the desert of Midian, and everything he once hoped to be has been left behind. Then, one day, he sees a bush burning that is not consumed. What follows is one of the most important encounters in the Bible. God reveals his name, announces his plan, and commissions an unwilling servant. Almost everything that comes later in the Old Testament, the exodus, the covenant, the law, the prophets, grows out of this scene.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Moses comes to Horeb, “the mountain of God,” and sees “the angel of the LORD” in a flame of fire in the midst of a bush that is not consumed (3:1-2).
2. God calls, “Moses, Moses!” and tells him not to come near, “for the place on which you are standing is holy ground” (3:4-5).
3. God says, “I am the God of your father, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob” (3:6). Moses hides his face.
4. “I have surely seen the affliction of my people who are in Egypt and have heard their cry…and I have come down to deliver them” (3:7-8).
5. Moses asks, “Who am I that I should go to Pharaoh?” God answers, “But I will be with you” (3:11-12).

6. Moses asks for God's name. God says, "I AM WHO I AM...Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you" (3:14).
7. God adds, "The LORD, the God of your fathers...has sent me to you. This is my name forever, and thus I am to be remembered throughout all generations" (3:15).
8. Moses offers objections: they will not believe me (4:1), I am not eloquent (4:10). God gives him signs, and reminds him, "Who has made man's mouth?" (4:11).
9. God is angry at Moses' final request, "Oh, my Lord, please send someone else" (4:13), but provides his brother Aaron as a spokesman (4:14-16).
10. God tells Moses to say to Pharaoh, "Israel is my firstborn son...Let my son go that he may serve me" (4:22-23). The people believe and worship (4:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The bush that burns without being consumed is a picture of God himself. Fire is a common symbol of God's holy presence, and here it burns without destroying what it touches. God's holiness is dangerous, and yet it does not have to be fatal. That is a hint of what is to come in the tabernacle, and in Christ.

The ground is holy because God is there, not because of anything about the place. Moses is told to take off his sandals. It is a physical way of saying that he is in the presence of someone infinitely greater than he is. Many of the Bible's accounts of meeting God begin this way, and they end with someone who has been changed.

Now look at how God introduces himself. First as the God of the fathers: Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. He is the God who made promises. Then as the God who sees, hears, knows, and comes down. These are verbs of nearness, and they are what Israel needs to hear. Then God sends Moses, and the sending is hard, because Moses does not want to go.

Moses' objections are worth looking at one by one. "Who am I?" is a question of worthiness, and God does not answer it by telling Moses that he is great. He answers by saying, "I will be with you." The solution to his smallness is God's presence. "What is your name?" is a question about God's character, and the answer is the most mysterious in Scripture. "They will not believe me" is a question of credibility, and God gives signs. "I am not eloquent" is a question of ability, and God replies, "Who has made man's mouth?" Every excuse is met with a reminder of who God is.

The name "I AM WHO I AM" has been studied for thousands of years. It seems to say that God is self-existent: he does not depend on anything else, and he simply is. It also seems to say that he will be what he will be: he is free, and he will show himself faithful. The name

connected to it, the LORD (Yahweh), becomes the personal name by which Israel knows him. You will see that name in capital letters throughout your English Bible. Tomorrow's doctrinal day will look at it more closely.

Finally, notice what God calls Israel: "my firstborn son." This is the language of family. Before the law, before the covenant at Sinai, God says that Israel is his son. Redemption is not a business arrangement. It is the rescue of a child.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus uses the burning bush to teach about the resurrection (Mark 12:26-27). He also speaks the divine name of himself: "Before Abraham was, I am" (John 8:58), and the "I am" sayings in John (6:35; 8:12; 10:11; 11:25; 14:6). Hebrews 3:1-6 compares Moses and Jesus as faithful servants. Paul says that God's "power is made perfect in weakness" (2 Corinthians 12:9).

STEP 6

Application

Take off your shoes, so to speak. Before you pray this week, spend a minute simply remembering who you are speaking to.

Identify your own list of excuses: "Who am I? What if they do not listen? I am not good enough." Read God's answers to Moses as answers to you.

Say aloud, "I will be with you." If you can, write it on a card where you will see it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for being holy and near.
- Tell him where you feel inadequate for what he asks, and ask him for his presence.
- Ask him to help you go where he sends and speak what he gives.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 14

"God said to Moses, I AM WHO I AM. And he said, Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you."

EXODUS 3:14

DAY 96 · WEEK 14

Exodus 3:13-15; Exodus 34:5-7

The Existence and Attributes of God

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 3:13-15 and Exodus 34:5-7. The first passage is the revelation of God's name at the burning bush. The second is God's own description of his character, given after Israel's sin with the golden calf. Read them together, and ask what each says about who God is.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the first doctrinal pause in Unit 5. Each time you meet one of these days, you step back from the story and ask what the Bible teaches. Today the topic is the most basic one: who God is. You have just read the call of Moses, where God revealed his name and described himself as the God of the fathers. Now you look at the two most important self-descriptions in the Old Testament. One tells you that God exists on his own. The other tells you what God is like.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Moses asks, "If I come to the people of Israel and say to them, The God of your fathers has sent me to you, and they ask me, What is his name? what shall I say to them?" (3:13).
2. God answers, "I AM WHO I AM" and "I AM has sent me to you" (3:14).
3. He then says, "The LORD, the God of your fathers…has sent me to you. This is my name forever" (3:15).
4. In Exodus 34, Moses is on Mount Sinai after Israel's sin with the golden calf. The LORD passes before him and proclaims, "The LORD, the LORD" (34:6).
5. God describes himself as "a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness" (34:6).

6. He “keeps steadfast love for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin” (34:7).

7. But he is also one “who will by no means clear the guilty, visiting the iniquity of the fathers on the children and the children’s children, to the third and the fourth generation” (34:7).

8. Moses quickly bows his head and worships (34:8).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

What is God like? The Bible’s answer starts with what theologians call his “aseity,” from a Latin phrase meaning “from himself.” God has life in himself. He does not need anything or anyone. He was not created, and nothing sustains him. When God says, “I AM WHO I AM,” he is saying, among other things, that he is the one who simply is. Everything else depends on him, and he depends on nothing. This is the foundation for all that follows. It means that God is not one more thing in the universe, even the greatest of them. He is the Creator of everything that is not himself.

The name given at the burning bush, written in English Bibles as “the LORD” in capital letters, is God’s personal name, Yahweh. It is related to the verb “to be,” and it speaks of his eternal, unchangeable presence. He is faithful to his promises because he does not change. Malachi 3:6 says, “For I the LORD do not change; therefore you, O children of Jacob, are not consumed.” James 1:17 speaks of the “Father of lights, with whom there is no variation or shadow due to change.” This is what theologians call God’s immutability. It does not mean that God is cold or distant. It means that his character and purposes are utterly reliable.

Then there is the self-description in Exodus 34:6-7, which becomes the most quoted passage in the Old Testament. Over and over, in the Psalms, the Prophets, and Nehemiah, writers return to these words (Numbers 14:18; Nehemiah 9:17; Psalm 103:8; Joel 2:13; Jonah 4:2). It is God’s own summary of his character. Notice how it starts: with mercy, grace, patience, steadfast love, and faithfulness. These are the words that come first. God’s character is, above all, a character of love. And yet the passage does not stop there. God “will by no means clear the guilty.” He is holy and just. His love is not weak, and his justice is not harsh.

Theologians sometimes divide God’s attributes into two groups. Some are incommunicable, meaning that they belong to God alone: his self-existence, his infinity, his unchangeableness, his omnipresence, his omniscience, his omnipotence. Others are communicable, meaning that human beings, made in his image, can reflect them in a limited way: love, mercy, justice, holiness, wisdom, faithfulness. This division helps explain why the Bible calls us to be like God (Ephesians 5:1) and also reminds us that he is infinitely beyond us.

The two attributes in tension in Exodus 34 are love and justice, and the rest of the Bible is the story of how they meet. How can a God who forgives iniquity also refuse to clear the guilty? The answer is not given here. It is given at the cross, where, as Paul writes, God is "just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus" (Romans 3:26). The two halves of Exodus 34:7 are held together in Christ.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Look at the setting of each passage. The first comes at the beginning of God's work of redemption, when he sends Moses to bring Israel out of Egypt. The second comes after Israel has broken the covenant by worshiping the golden calf. In the first, God's name is an assurance that he will keep his promises. In the second, God's character is his answer to the question that Israel's sin raises: is it over?

God's response to a failed covenant is to describe himself. He does not explain a method or lay out terms. He says who he is. "The LORD, the LORD, a God merciful and gracious." The ground for hope after sin is not that people will do better but that God is who he is. This is what makes grace possible.

It matters, too, that Moses bows and worships. A right knowledge of God does not lead to pride but to worship. If you ever study the doctrine of God and find it making you proud or merely curious, something has gone wrong. The right response is Moses' response: to bow your head, and worship.

Finally, take note of the two kinds of statements in 34:7. They are not in contradiction. God is serious about sin because he is good. And he is willing to forgive because he is good. If he ignored sin, he would not be good. If he never forgave, he would not be merciful. The God of the Bible is both.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus claims the divine name in John 8:58 and says, "Whoever has seen me has seen the Father" (John 14:9). John 1:14 says that the Word "dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory…full of grace and truth," echoing "abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness." Paul writes that God put forward Christ "to show his righteousness, because in his divine forbearance he had passed over former sins" (Romans 3:25).

STEP 6

Application

Try to describe God, in your own words, using the list in Exodus 34:6-7. Which attribute do you find easiest to believe? Which is harder?

If you find it hard to believe in God's mercy, read these verses again, and notice that he said them about himself after Israel's worst sin.

Pray the passage as a prayer: "LORD, you are merciful and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness." Let it become your first thought about God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for who he is: self-existing, unchanging, merciful, and just.

Thank him that in Jesus the name I AM is made known.

Tell him which of his attributes you most need to remember today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 14

"God said to Moses, I AM WHO I AM. And he said, Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you."

EXODUS 3:14

DAY 97 · WEEK 14

Psalm 106:1-23

Israel's history of unfaithfulness, grace despite rebellion

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 106:1-23. This is a confession psalm, a summary of Israel's early failures told from the standpoint of people who know that their own record is no better. Read it slowly and listen for the one line that keeps the history from being a list of defeats.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

You have just begun the story of the exodus, and this psalm looks back on it from centuries later. It is one of the great historical psalms of the Bible, along with Psalms 78, 105, and 136. The author does not know the details of how it will all turn out, but he knows that Israel has a long history of failing God, and that God has a long history of being faithful. The psalm will return in two parts, and between them you will read the whole exodus story. Think of it as a preview.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm begins with praise: "Praise the LORD! Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever!" (v. 1).
2. A confession follows: "Both we and our fathers have sinned; we have committed iniquity; we have done wickedness" (v. 6).
3. At the Red Sea, the fathers "did not consider your wondrous works…but rebelled by the sea" (v. 7).
4. "Yet he saved them for his name's sake, that he might make known his mighty power" (v. 8).
5. "He rebuked the Red Sea, and it became dry" (v. 9). "Then they believed his words; they sang his praise" (v. 12).

6. “But they soon forgot his works; they did not wait for his counsel” (v. 13).
7. In the wilderness, they “craved to the full,” and God “gave them what they asked, but sent a wasting disease among them” (vv. 14-15).
8. The earth swallowed Dathan and Abiram, who challenged Moses’ authority (vv. 16-18).
9. “They made a calf in Horeb and worshiped a metal image. They exchanged the glory of God for the image of an ox that eats grass” (vv. 19-20).
10. “Therefore he said he would destroy them, had not Moses, his chosen one, stood in the breach before him, to turn away his wrath from destroying them” (v. 23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The structure of the psalm is a lesson in itself. It begins and ends with praise. In the middle, it tells a long story of failure. The psalm is not a bitter complaint about Israel. It is an act of worship that tells the truth about sin and the truth about God.

Notice the first confession in verse 6: “Both we and our fathers have sinned.” The psalmist does not blame his ancestors. He includes himself. This is the heart of honest confession. It is not enough to say that the past generation failed. We are part of the same story, with the same tendencies.

Then look at the pattern in the history. Israel sees a miracle and believes. A few days later, they forget. This is the thing the psalm keeps saying: “They soon forgot his works.” Forgetting is a form of sin, and it is the root of other sins. When you stop remembering what God has done, you stop trusting what he will do. This is why the Bible so often calls people to remember: to keep the Passover, to set up memorial stones, to tell the story to children.

The most shocking detail is verse 20: “They exchanged the glory of God for the image of an ox that eats grass.” It is meant to sound absurd. The people have seen the greatest display of God’s power in history, and they traded it for a statue of a grass-eating animal. Paul will pick up this phrase in Romans 1:23 to describe the human condition. We all do this, with money, success, comfort, and image.

But the line that carries the psalm is verse 8. “Yet he saved them for his name’s sake.” God’s rescue does not depend on Israel’s merit, since they did not have any. It rests on his own character and name. That is the foundation of grace.

The last verse in the section points to a mediator. “Moses, his chosen one, stood in the breach.” A breach is a gap in a wall, and a man standing in it takes the full force of the attack. God would have destroyed Israel, but Moses stepped between. It is a picture of what Christ will do on a much grander scale.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul uses the phrase of verse 20 in Romans 1:23, and in 1 Corinthians 10:1-13 he uses Israel's wilderness history as a warning and encouragement to the church. Hebrews 3:7-19 calls believers not to harden their hearts as Israel did. Ezekiel 22:30 describes God looking for someone to "stand in the breach" and finding no one. Jesus stands in that breach fully.

STEP 6

Application

Make a short list of what God has done for you in the past year. Put it somewhere you will see it. Forgetting is the first step toward drifting.

Confess honestly, as the psalmist does, using the word "we." Pray for your church and community, not only for yourself.

Ask yourself what you are tempted to exchange for the glory of God, and bring it to Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the lesser things you have exchanged for God's glory.
- Thank him for saving you for his name's sake.
- Thank him for the one who stands in the breach for you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 14

"God said to Moses, I AM WHO I AM. And he said, Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you."

EXODUS 3:14

DAY 98 · WEEK 14

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Exodus 3:14 slowly, several times, and then try to say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"God said to Moses, I AM WHO I AM. And he said, Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you."

EXODUS 3:14

REST

Meditation

Exodus 3:14 gives you a name to carry with you, and it is not an easy one. "I AM WHO I AM." It is the most compact statement about God in the Bible, and it has been a source of wonder for the people of God for three thousand years.

Begin with the simplicity of it. God does not say, "I am the powerful one," or "I am the king," or "I am the one who will save you." He says, "I AM." He is. He exists. He is the source of all that is, and he needs nothing. Before there was anything, there was God.

Notice who God says this to. It is not to philosophers or scholars. It is to a shepherd who is afraid, in the middle of a desert. The God who exists in himself, who does not depend on anything, has come to a nobody in a wilderness to say that he will rescue a nation of slaves. The greatest being in the universe is the one who sees the affliction of his people.

And notice the second half: “I AM has sent me to you.” The name is not just a statement about God’s nature. It is a promise to his people. He will be there. He will be what they need. “I will be with you,” he said to Moses in verse 12, and the name is the guarantee.

For the Christian, there is a final note. Jesus said, “Before Abraham was, I am” (John 8:58). The one who spoke from the bush became flesh and walked among us. Everything that is true of God’s name is true of Jesus.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the book of Exodus. You read how a new king arose who did not know Joseph, how Israel was enslaved, and how two midwives saved the Hebrew boys. You watched Moses be born, hidden in a basket, raised in Pharaoh’s house, and driven into the wilderness. You stood with him at the burning bush and heard God reveal his name. You saw him offer every excuse and God answer each with himself. On the doctrinal day, you studied the existence and attributes of God, from his self-existence in the name I AM to his character of mercy and justice in Exodus 34. In Psalm 106, you read a confession of Israel’s early failures and heard the line that holds it together: God saved them for his name’s sake. The week taught that God sees, hears, and remembers, and that he comes down to rescue.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Moses had a list of excuses, and God answered each one with a promise of his own presence. What is your list of excuses for something God has asked of you? Write them down, and next to each one write a promise from God.

How does Jesus’ statement, “Before Abraham was, I am,” change the way you read the burning bush? What does it mean to you that the God of Exodus 3 has come in the flesh?

Which part of the description in Exodus 34:6-7 do you find hardest to believe about God? Why? How would your life change if you believed it more fully?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he sees, hears, and knows.

Rest in who he is, and tell him what you are laying down this Sabbath.

Thank him for Jesus, in whom his name is fulfilled.

DAY 99 · WEEK 15

Exodus 5:1-7:25

Pharaoh hardens; Moses discouraged; the plagues begin

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 5:1-7:25. Moses and Aaron go to Pharaoh for the first time, and everything gets worse. Read it as the story of a man who obeys God and sees the result make his people's lives harder, and notice how God responds to Moses' discouragement.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

You have just left Moses at the burning bush with a commission and a promise. Now he goes to Egypt and puts it to the test. The next several chapters tell the story of the ten plagues, which are the most dramatic series of events in the Old Testament. They are a contest between the LORD and the greatest empire on earth. But before the plagues begin, there is a long scene of disappointment. The first attempt to free Israel does not work. In the process, the question the whole book turns on is made clear: who is the LORD, and will Pharaoh obey him?

STEP 3

Observation

1. Moses and Aaron say to Pharaoh, "Thus says the LORD, the God of Israel, Let my people go, that they may hold a feast to me in the wilderness" (5:1).
2. Pharaoh answers, "Who is the LORD, that I should obey his voice and let Israel go? I do not know the LORD, and moreover, I will not let Israel go" (5:2).
3. Pharaoh makes the labor harder by requiring bricks without straw (5:6-9).
4. The Israelite foremen blame Moses: "You have made us stink before Pharaoh" (5:21).
5. Moses complains to God: "O Lord, why have you done evil to this people? Why did you ever send me?" (5:22).

6. God answers, “Now you shall see what I will do to Pharaoh” (6:1), and he says again, “I am the LORD” (6:2, 6, 7, 8).
7. God makes a series of promises: “I will bring you out…I will deliver you…I will redeem you…I will take you to be my people, and I will be your God” (6:6-7).
8. But the people “did not listen to Moses, because of their broken spirit and harsh slavery” (6:9). Moses says he has “uncircumcised lips” (6:12).
9. God says, “I have made you like God to Pharaoh, and your brother Aaron shall be your prophet” (7:1). He says, “I will harden Pharaoh’s heart” (7:3).
10. Aaron’s staff becomes a serpent and swallows the magicians’ serpents (7:10-12). The Nile is turned to blood (7:14-25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Pharaoh’s first question is the right one. “Who is the LORD?” He does not know, and he will find out. The whole sequence of plagues is the answer. God says over and over that the purpose is that Egypt and Israel will know that he is the LORD (7:5). It is a knowledge that comes through action.

The worsening of Israel’s conditions is a test of Moses’ faith, and it is a test for every believer. Often, when you try to obey God, things get harder before they get better. The people blame Moses. Moses blames God. This is one of the more honest scenes in the Bible. Moses does not hide what he feels. He says, “Why did you ever send me?” And God does not rebuke him. He answers with a restatement of who he is and what he will do.

God’s answer in chapter 6 is the heart of the passage. Listen to the four, or five, “I will” statements: bring out, deliver, redeem, take, and later in verse 8, bring in. This is a gospel in miniature. He will free them from the burden, rescue them from slavery, and redeem them with an outstretched arm. And then comes the covenant goal: “I will take you to be my people, and I will be your God.” The purpose of redemption is relationship. They are rescued in order to belong.

The people cannot hear it. Their spirit is broken. This is another honest detail. Some pain makes it hard to receive good news. God does not scold them for it. He continues to act.

The hardening of Pharaoh is a topic that deserves care. The text speaks of it in several ways. God says he will harden Pharaoh’s heart (4:21; 7:3). Pharaoh’s heart is also described as hardened without any stated agent (7:13), and later Pharaoh hardens his own heart (8:15, 32). The Bible holds these together: God is sovereign over Pharaoh’s will, and Pharaoh is responsible for his choices. Paul will take this up in Romans 9:17-18, saying that God raised

up Pharaoh to show his power. You may find this hard. It is worth sitting with the discomfort rather than explaining it away. The first thing to see is that God's purpose is to reveal who he is, and the second is that Pharaoh was not coerced into evil. He was an oppressor who did what he wanted.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus says to his disciples that "in the world you will have tribulation," and then, "take heart; I have overcome the world" (John 16:33). The four "I will" promises of 6:6-7 are echoed in Jesus' words in John 10:28 and in Titus 2:14, where he "gave himself for us to redeem us from all lawlessness and to purify for himself a people for his own possession." Romans 9:14-24 takes up the question of Pharaoh's hardening.

STEP 6

Application

Are you discouraged because obeying God made things harder? Take Moses' complaint to God, as he did. He can bear it.

Memorize Exodus 6:6-7. Use the promises as your own. Notice that they are about God's action, not yours.

If someone in your life is too broken to hear good news, pray for them and keep showing them love.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring your complaint about how hard things are to God, honestly.
- Ask him to remind you who he is.
- Ask for the courage to keep going.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 15

“The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you.”

EXODUS 12:13

DAY 100 · WEEK 15

Exodus 8:1-9:35

Plagues of frogs, gnats, flies, livestock, and boils

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 8:1-9:35. These chapters contain the plagues of frogs, gnats, flies, the death of livestock, boils, and hail. Do not rush. Look for the phrase “that you may know,” and watch what happens each time Pharaoh seems to give in.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The plagues are not random disasters. Each one is aimed at something the Egyptians trusted, such as the Nile, the frogs associated with the goddess Heqet, the animals associated with their religion, and the sky. God says that through the plagues he will execute “judgments” on all the gods of Egypt (Exodus 12:12). They are a contest between the LORD and the powers that seemed to rule Egypt. They are also a mercy, because they give Pharaoh repeated chances to let Israel go.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Moses says, “Let my people go, that they may serve me” (8:1). The plague of frogs fills the land, and Pharaoh asks Moses to pray to the LORD to remove it (8:8).
2. When the frogs die, Pharaoh “hardened his heart and would not listen to them” (8:15).
3. The magicians cannot produce gnats and say to Pharaoh, “This is the finger of God” (8:19).
4. With the flies, God says, “I will set apart the land of Goshen…that you may know that I am the LORD in the midst of the earth” (8:22).
5. The livestock of Egypt die, but not one of the animals of Israel (9:6).

6. The boils afflict the magicians themselves, so that they "could not stand before Moses" (9:11). "The LORD hardened the heart of Pharaoh" (9:12).
7. God says to Pharaoh, "For this purpose I have raised you up, to show you my power, so that my name may be proclaimed in all the earth" (9:16).
8. Before the hail, God offers a chance to shelter the servants and livestock. Some Egyptians who feared the word of the LORD brought them in (9:19-21).
9. Pharaoh says, "I have sinned this time; the LORD is in the right, and I and my people are in the wrong" (9:27), and then he sins again (9:34-35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

There is a pattern in the plagues, and it is worth noticing. Pharaoh is confronted. He stalls, then gives way under pressure, and then goes back on his promise when the pressure is lifted. This is a picture of a heart that is not changed by judgment alone. Frogs, gnats, flies, and boils make him say what he must, but nothing in him changes. This is a warning to every one of us that pain alone does not make a person repent. You need a new heart.

The magicians are a surprising feature of the story. At first they copy Moses' signs. But with the gnats, they fail and confess, "This is the finger of God." Even Pharaoh's own advisers have to admit that something beyond them is at work. And by the sixth plague they cannot even stand. The power of the Egyptian gods is shown to be empty.

God makes a distinction between Egypt and Israel. In the land of Goshen there are no flies, and Israel's livestock do not die. The plagues are not simple natural disasters. They are directed, and God protects his own. This is the theme of redemption, to which the narrative keeps returning: God sets his people apart.

The most important statement in these chapters comes in 9:16. "For this purpose I have raised you up, to show you my power, so that my name may be proclaimed in all the earth." God's goal is bigger than freeing Israel. He wants all the world to know who he is. You can see that the exodus is always for the sake of his name, and that this is a good thing. The best thing that could happen to any person is to know the true God.

Then there is the hail. God gives a warning to those who will hear. Some Egyptians, "who feared the word of the LORD," gather their servants and flocks indoors. This is a small piece of mercy in the middle of judgment: even in Egypt, anyone who trusted God's word was spared. It is a hint of what the book will say later, that foreigners could join Israel (12:38).

Pharaoh's confession in 9:27 is the most striking detail. He says all the right words: "I have sinned. The LORD is in the right." But by verse 34 he is sinning again. A confession without repentance is just speech. Compare it to Psalm 106, where Israel also sang God's praise and soon forgot.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 16 describes the bowls of judgment in language drawn from these plagues. Romans 9:17 quotes Exodus 9:16. Jesus said that "everyone to whom much was given, of him much will be required" (Luke 12:48). Jesus also distinguishes true repentance from regret in the parable of the two sons (Matthew 21:28-32) and in Paul's words about "godly grief" in 2 Corinthians 7:10.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself if there is a pattern in your life of making promises to God under pressure and forgetting them afterward. Bring it to him honestly.

If you are tempted to think that God's judgments are arbitrary, notice how patient he is in these chapters. He gives repeated warnings and offers shelter.

Remember that God sets his people apart. Thank him for the ways he has marked you as his own.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for his patience with those who resist him, and for the mercy in his warnings.

Ask him for a heart that truly repents, not just a mouth that says so.

Thank him for setting his people apart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 15

"The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you."

EXODUS 12:13

DAY 101 · WEEK 15

Exodus 10:1-11:10

Locusts, darkness, and the warning of the firstborn

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 39 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 10:1-11:10. These chapters contain the plagues of locusts and darkness, and the announcement of the last plague. Read them as the climax of the confrontation, and notice how Pharaoh's bargaining shows what his heart is really protecting.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Seven plagues have passed. Egypt is ruined: the Nile is blood, the land is covered in frogs, flies, and dead animals, and its crops have been shattered by hail. Pharaoh's own officials say, "Do you not yet understand that Egypt is destroyed?" (10:7). Still he refuses. The last three plagues are the most terrible, and they lead up to the event that will define Israel's identity for the rest of its history.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God tells Moses to go to Pharaoh, "that I may show these signs of mine among them, and that you may tell in the hearing of your son and of your grandson how I have dealt harshly with the Egyptians" (10:1-2).
2. Pharaoh's servants beg, "How long shall this man be a snare to us? Let the men go, that they may serve the LORD their God" (10:7).
3. Pharaoh bargains: only the men may go (10:11). The locusts eat everything that is left after the hail (10:12-15).
4. After the locusts, Pharaoh says, "I have sinned against the LORD your God, and against you" (10:16), and then hardens his heart again.
5. The ninth plague is "a darkness to be felt" that lasts three days, but "all the people of Israel had light where they lived" (10:21-23).

6. Pharaoh offers another bargain: the people may go, but their flocks and herds must stay. Moses answers, "Not a hoof shall be left behind" (10:24-26).
7. Pharaoh says, "Get away from me; take care never to see my face again" (10:28). Moses replies, "You have spoken rightly. I will not see your face again" (10:29).
8. God announces the last plague: "About midnight I will go out in the midst of Egypt, and every firstborn in the land of Egypt shall die" (11:4-5).
9. "Not a dog shall growl against any of the people of Israel...that you may know that the LORD makes a distinction between Egypt and Israel" (11:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Pharaoh's bargains are worth studying, because people still bargain with God in the same ways. First he says, "Go and sacrifice here in the land." That is, serve God, but on my terms and in my territory. Then he says, "Only the men may go." That is, serve God, but leave your children and keep your families under my control. Then, "Go, but leave your flocks." That is, serve God, but keep what you own under my power. Each time Moses refuses. "Not a hoof shall be left behind." Everything belongs to God, and nothing can be held back.

The pattern is not about distant history. Many people want a version of faith that costs them nothing: Christianity at church but not at home, in the heart but not in the wallet, for the individual but not for the family. Moses' answer is that God asks for the whole thing.

The plague of darkness is the strangest. It is described as a "darkness to be felt." It was so thick that people did not see one another or rise from their places for three days. This is a reversal of the first day of creation, when God said, "Let there be light." The land of Egypt is un-created. It is also a picture of what it means to live without God: a darkness that you can feel. And in Goshen, the people of God had light. That is a vivid image of the difference God makes.

Pharaoh's final words to Moses are chilling. "Take care never to see my face again." He sends away the one who has brought him warnings and a way out. The man who says no to God's messenger has sealed his own fate. Moses' answer, "You have spoken rightly," is calm. The time for negotiation is over.

The last plague is announced in 11:4-8, and the tone is grave. Moses speaks "in hot anger" (11:8), but the message is clear and sorrowful: there will be a great cry throughout Egypt such as never was before. God is not delighting in this. It is a judgment on a nation that has killed Israel's sons (Exodus 1:22) and refused to repent. And in the middle of the announcement is a promise: "The LORD makes a distinction between Egypt and Israel." You will see tomorrow how.

STEP 5

Connection

The darkness of the ninth plague has parallels in the darkness at the cross (Matthew 27:45), when Jesus, the light of the world, bore God's judgment. Paul writes in Colossians 1:13 that God "has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son." John 1:5 says, "The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it." Luke 14:33 says, "Any one of you who does not renounce all that he has cannot be my disciple."

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself where you are bargaining with God. Which parts of your life are you trying to keep out of his reach? It may be your time, your money, your family, or a relationship. Bring that area to him this week.

Thank God that you have light. If you know someone who is in darkness, pray for them, and look for a chance to speak of Christ.

Pray for those who do not know God and who are hardening themselves against him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have bargained with God or held something back.
- Ask him to take your whole self, your family, and your possessions.
- Thank him for bringing you out of darkness into his light.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 15

"The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you."

EXODUS 12:13

DAY 102 · WEEK 15

Exodus 12:1-13:16

The Passover instituted, the lamb and the blood

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 67 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 12:1-13:16. This is the central chapter of the Old Testament's story of redemption. Read it slowly and with great care. Mark each instruction about the lamb, and notice what saves the people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Everything in the book of Exodus has been leading to this night. God is about to strike Egypt with the last plague, and he gives Israel a way to be protected: the Passover. It is the foundational event of Israel's national life, and the Jewish people have kept the feast ever since. For Christians, it is the great shadow of the cross. Jesus died at Passover time, and he is called "our Passover lamb" (1 Corinthians 5:7). Understanding the Passover is the key to understanding what Jesus did.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "This month shall be for you the beginning of months. It shall be the first month of the year for you" (12:2).
2. Each household is to take a lamb "without blemish, a male a year old" (12:5).
3. The lamb is kept until the fourteenth day, and then "the whole assembly of the congregation of Israel shall kill their lambs at twilight" (12:6).
4. They are to take some of the blood "and put it on the two doorposts and the lintel of the houses" (12:7).
5. They are to eat the meat roasted, with unleavened bread and bitter herbs, "with your belt fastened, your sandals on your feet, and your staff in your hand" (12:8-11).

6. “It is the LORD’s Passover” (12:11).
7. God says, “The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you” (12:13).
8. The feast of unleavened bread is to be kept as a memorial, and children are to be taught what it means (12:14-20, 26-27).
9. At midnight, the LORD struck down all the firstborn in Egypt, and “there was a great cry in Egypt, for there was not a house where someone was not dead” (12:29-30).
10. Pharaoh calls for Moses and says, “Up, go out from among my people” (12:31). A “mixed multitude” goes up with Israel (12:38).
11. God commands that every firstborn male be consecrated to him, and that every firstborn son be redeemed (13:1-2, 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Passover is a story about substitution. In every house in Egypt, the firstborn was under a sentence of death. The difference between Israel and Egypt was not that Israel was more righteous. The difference was that, in Israel’s homes, a lamb had died in place of the firstborn son. The blood on the doorpost was the sign that the death had already occurred. When God saw it, he passed over.

Look at the details. The lamb is “without blemish.” It is chosen on the tenth day and kept in the house for four days, long enough for the family to become attached to it. It is killed by the whole community. Its blood is applied to the door. The meat is eaten. Every part of the ritual teaches something. The lamb is innocent. The death is public. The blood is a visible sign. And the family has to take it in.

Notice how little the people do. They do not fight, or earn their freedom. They do not even go out of the house. They shelter under the blood. This is why the New Testament uses the Passover to teach grace. We are saved not by what we do but by the blood of the Lamb applied to us.

The tone of the ritual is also important. They are to eat in haste, ready to leave. It is a night of judgment and of rescue. Salvation is not a calm event. But it is secure.

The Passover is also designed to be remembered. Three times in these chapters God tells the people to teach their children: “What do you mean by this service?” (12:26). The parents are to say, “It is the sacrifice of the LORD’s Passover, for he passed over the houses of the people of Israel in Egypt” (12:27). Redemption has to be told, again and again, to every generation.

Chapter 13 adds a second teaching: the firstborn belongs to God. Every firstborn son had to be redeemed, bought back, with the sacrifice of a lamb (13:13). A father would answer his son's question by saying, "By a strong hand the LORD brought us out of Egypt" (13:14). Redemption creates ownership. Those who have been bought belong to the one who bought them.

STEP 5

Connection

John the Baptist said of Jesus, "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29). Jesus was crucified at Passover time, and John notes that "not one of his bones will be broken" (John 19:36, quoting Exodus 12:46). At the Last Supper, he took the Passover meal and gave it new meaning (Luke 22:14-20). Peter says we were ransomed "with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot" (1 Peter 1:18-19). Hebrews 11:28 says Moses kept the Passover "by faith."

STEP 6

Application

When you take the Lord's Supper, think of the Passover. You are not earning anything. You are receiving the benefits of a Lamb who died in your place.

Ask yourself if you are relying on the blood of Christ or on your own record. Say aloud, "When he sees the blood, he will pass over me."

Think about how you can tell the story of your redemption to a child or a friend this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the blood of the Lamb, and say in your own words what it means that he passes over you.
- Ask him to help you tell the story to someone younger.
- Tell him you trust Christ and not yourself.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 15

"The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you."

EXODUS 12:13

DAY 103 · WEEK 15

Exodus 13:17-14:31

The Red Sea crossing, redemption through water

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 13:17-14:31. This is the crossing of the Red Sea, the climax of the exodus. Read the story as a drama in three parts: Israel's fear, God's promise through Moses, and the crossing itself.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has left Egypt, with the bones of Joseph carried along as a sign of the promise (13:19). But the journey is not easy. God leads them by a longer route, and then into what looks like a trap, with the sea in front and Pharaoh's army behind. It is a test of whether they will trust the God who has just rescued them. Everything that follows in Israel's history, in the Psalms, and in the New Testament, looks back to this moment.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God did not lead them by the road through the land of the Philistines, "for God said, Lest the people change their minds when they see war and return to Egypt" (13:17).
2. "The LORD went before them by day in a pillar of cloud to lead them along the way, and by night in a pillar of fire to give them light" (13:21).
3. God tells Moses to camp by the sea, so that Pharaoh will think they are wandering confused. "And I will get glory over Pharaoh and all his host" (14:4).
4. Pharaoh changes his mind and pursues with six hundred chariots (14:5-9).
5. The people cry out in fear and say to Moses, "Is it because there were no graves in Egypt that you have taken us away to die in the wilderness?" (14:11).

6. Moses answers, “Fear not, stand firm, and see the salvation of the LORD, which he will work for you today...The LORD will fight for you, and you have only to be silent” (14:13-14).
7. The angel of God and the pillar of cloud move between Israel and the Egyptians, bringing darkness to one side and light to the other (14:19-20).
8. Moses stretches out his hand, a strong east wind drives the sea back, and “the people of Israel went into the midst of the sea on dry ground, the waters being a wall to them on their right hand and on their left” (14:21-22).
9. The waters return and cover the Egyptians. “Not one of them remained” (14:28).
10. “Thus the LORD saved Israel that day from the hand of the Egyptians...And the people feared the LORD, and they believed in the LORD and in his servant Moses” (14:30-31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to see is that God led them into the trap on purpose. This is not a case of bad navigation. God said, “I will get glory over Pharaoh.” The danger was real, and the people were right to be afraid. But the danger was part of God’s plan to show his power. This is a theme throughout Scripture: God sometimes brings his people to the end of their own resources so that his salvation will be clearly his.

Moses’ answer is the center of the passage, and one of the great statements of faith in the Bible. “Fear not, stand firm, and see the salvation of the LORD.” There are three commands: do not be afraid, stand still, and watch. This is not a call to passivity in everything, but in this moment there was nothing Israel could do. They were not going to fight their way out. The next line is the promise: “The LORD will fight for you, and you have only to be silent.” The deliverance would be entirely God’s work.

Then notice how God works. He did not remove the sea. He divided it. Israel walked through on dry ground with water on each side. The very thing that seemed to be their death, the sea, became their path. And the same sea became the Egyptians’ grave. The same event is salvation for one people and judgment for another.

The last verses tell you what the miracle accomplished in the hearts of the people. They “feared the LORD, and they believed in the LORD and in his servant Moses.” Redemption produced faith. We saw in Psalm 106 that the faith did not last, but at that moment it was real.

For the New Testament writers, the crossing of the sea is a picture of baptism. Paul says that "all were baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea" (1 Corinthians 10:2). Passing through the water means leaving the old master behind and belonging to a new leader. It also looks to the cross, where Christ, the greater Moses, passes through the waters of judgment so that his people can walk through on dry ground.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 43:2 says, "When you pass through the waters, I will be with you." Paul compares the crossing to baptism in 1 Corinthians 10:1-2. Peter says that "baptism…now saves you" as an appeal to God for a good conscience (1 Peter 3:21), after speaking of the flood. Revelation 15:3 describes the saints singing "the song of Moses, the servant of God."

STEP 6

Application

Think of a place where you feel hemmed in, with the sea in front and an enemy behind. Say aloud, "The LORD will fight for you, and you have only to be silent."

Take a few minutes of true silence in prayer this week. Resist the urge to fix the situation, and watch for God's salvation.

Remember your baptism, if you have been baptized. If you have not, ask what it would mean to take that step.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you fear when you face a sea you cannot cross.
- Ask him to fight for you and to teach you to be still.
- Thank him for the salvation he worked in Christ.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 15

“The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you.”

EXODUS 12:13

DAY 104 · WEEK 15

Psalm 106:24-48

Israel's rebellion in the wilderness; God's mercy endures

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Psalm · 25 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 106:24-48. This is the second half of the confession psalm you began on Day 97. Read it as a story that moves from rebellion to rescue, and look for the verses that describe what God does when his people forget him.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

On Day 97, you read the first half of this psalm, which described Israel's failures at the Red Sea and at Horeb. Today you read the rest, which takes you through the wilderness, the entrance to the land, and the long years in Canaan. Because you have just read the crossing of the sea and the Passover, this psalm shows you what happens to a redeemed people who do not stay close to their Redeemer. It is a sober picture, and it ends with a plea.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Then they despised the pleasant land, having no faith in his promise" (v. 24). They "murmured in their tents" (v. 25).
2. God swore that he would cast them down in the wilderness (v. 26).
3. They yoked themselves to the Baal of Peor and ate sacrifices offered to the dead (v. 28).
4. Phinehas stood up and intervened, "and that was counted to him as righteousness from generation to generation forever" (vv. 30-31).
5. At the waters of Meribah, "it went ill with Moses on their account, for they made his spirit bitter, and he spoke rashly with his lips" (vv. 32-33).
6. They did not destroy the peoples as the LORD commanded, but "mingled with the nations and learned to do as they did" (vv. 34-35).

7. They sacrificed their sons and daughters to the demons (v. 37).
8. The LORD "was angry with his people, and he abhorred his heritage" (v. 40), and gave them into the hand of the nations.
9. "Nevertheless, he looked upon their distress, when he heard their cry. For their sake he remembered his covenant, and relented according to the abundance of his steadfast love" (vv. 44-45).
10. "Save us, O LORD our God, and gather us from among the nations, that we may give thanks to your holy name and glory in your praise" (v. 47).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The second half of this psalm is harder than the first. It spans many generations, and the failure is repeated. Each generation seems to start again. The sins are the same: unbelief, idolatry, and compromise. They do not trust God's promise of the land. They give themselves to other gods. They stop short of obedience and imitate the nations around them.

One phrase stands out: "They made his spirit bitter, and he spoke rashly with his lips." Even Moses, the faithful servant, is brought down by the people's sin. At Meribah, he struck the rock in anger, and because of it, was not allowed into the land (Numbers 20:1-13). This is a sad reminder that no human leader is perfect. Even the best of them fails. You need a greater Moses.

The story of Phinehas is one of those rare bright spots. His zeal turned away God's anger, and the psalm says that it was "counted to him as righteousness." The same phrase is used of Abraham in Genesis 15:6, and Paul uses it for the believer in Romans 4. The psalm presents righteousness as something credited. It is a theme that will return throughout the Bible.

The darkest verse is verse 37: they sacrificed their sons and daughters to demons. The people who had been rescued from Egypt, where Pharaoh murdered baby boys, now did the same thing to their own children. This shows how deep sin goes. Rescue from slavery does not remove the heart's tendency to evil.

And yet the psalm does not end in despair. In verse 44, "Nevertheless." It is one of the great words in the Bible. "He looked upon their distress, when he heard their cry. For their sake he remembered his covenant." This is exactly what you read in Exodus 2:24. God hears, and remembers, and relents. The foundation is "the abundance of his steadfast love." The psalm ends with a prayer for a future rescue: "Save us, O LORD our God." This is the prayer that Israel will pray in exile, and the prayer that the church prays as we wait for the final salvation.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that “these things happened to them as an example, but they were written down for our instruction” (1 Corinthians 10:11). Hebrews 3 and 4 call believers not to fall as Israel did. Romans 4:3-5 quotes Genesis 15:6 on righteousness being credited. Jesus is the greater Moses, who is faithful over God’s house as a Son (Hebrews 3:5-6). The “Nevertheless” of verse 44 finds its fullest expression in Ephesians 2:4: “But God, being rich in mercy.”

STEP 6

Application

Be honest about where you tend to compromise. Is there a pattern of imitating the world around you? Bring it to God and ask for help.

Read Psalm 106:44-45 as a promise to yourself in your weakness. Write the word “Nevertheless” on a card.

Pray the last verse for the church, asking God to gather his scattered and discouraged people.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the ways you see yourself in Israel’s drifting.
- Thank God for hearing and remembering his covenant.
- Ask him to gather his people and make them glad.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 15

“The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you.”

EXODUS 12:13

DAY 105 · WEEK 15

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Exodus 12:13 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone you trust.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you."

EXODUS 12:13

REST

Meditation

Exodus 12:13 is the gospel in one sentence. It was spoken on the night before the exodus, and it says everything about how God saves.

"The blood shall be a sign for you." The blood was a sign for the people inside the house, not for God. It was the thing that gave them confidence that the judgment would not touch them. They did not have to feel safe. They had a sign. When you are afraid, the promise is not that you will feel better, but that there is a sign: the blood.

"When I see the blood." It is God who sees the blood, and the sight of it is what determines what he does. Notice what is not said. God does not say, "When I see your goodness" or "When I see your repentance." He says, "When I see the blood." The ground of your safety is not what is in you but what is on the door. A lamb has died in your place.

“I will pass over you.” This is the great promise. Judgment is real, and it falls on Egypt. But those under the blood are safe. The word “pass over” is related to a Hebrew verb that means to hover protectively, like a bird over its nest (Isaiah 31:5). God does not just skip the house. He guards it.

“And no plague will befall you to destroy you.” The protection is complete.

For the Christian, the blood is the blood of Christ. “Since, therefore, we have now been justified by his blood, much more shall we be saved by him from the wrath of God” (Romans 5:9). There is no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus (Romans 8:1). Every time you doubt whether you are safe, return to this verse.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the story of the plagues and the exodus. You watched Moses go to Pharaoh and make things worse, and you heard God answer his complaint with the promise to bring out, deliver, redeem, and take. You read the plagues of frogs, gnats, flies, livestock, boils, and hail, and saw how Pharaoh gave way and hardened his heart again and again. You watched Pharaoh bargain, and Moses refuse to leave a hoof behind. You read the instructions for the Passover and heard God say, “When I see the blood, I will pass over you.” Then you walked through the Red Sea on dry ground and saw the waters close over Pharaoh’s army. In Psalm 106, you read a confession of Israel’s later unfaithfulness, and the one word that rescues the story: “Nevertheless.” The week taught that salvation is God’s work, secured by the blood of a substitute.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Pharaoh bargained with God, offering part but not all. What part of your life do you tend to hold back from God? What would it look like to say, “Not a hoof shall be left behind”?

How does the Passover lamb help you understand what Jesus did on the cross? Think about the details: without blemish, its blood applied, protection from judgment. What does it mean for you personally that Christ is your Passover lamb?

Moses told Israel at the sea, “The LORD will fight for you, and you have only to be silent.” What battle are you trying to fight on your own? What would it look like to be silent and let God fight?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that when he sees the blood, he passes over you.

Ask him to fight for you, and rest in him.

Tell him what you are tempted to trust apart from Christ.

DAY 106 · WEEK 16

Exodus 15:1-27

The song of Moses, redemption celebrated in worship

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 27 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 15:1-27. This is the first song in the Bible sung by the whole people of God. Read the first half aloud as a song of praise, and then read the second half as the first test after the song. Notice how quickly the singing is followed by complaining.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Red Sea is behind them, and the Egyptians are dead on the shore. For the first time in four hundred years, Israel is free. What does a free people do? They sing. Exodus 15 is the oldest extended poem in the Bible, and it is the model for the way that redemption is celebrated in worship. Moses and the people sing it, and Miriam leads the women in another song. It looks back at what God has done, and forward to what he will do. After the song comes the wilderness, and the first lesson in how fragile their praise can be.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will sing to the LORD, for he has triumphed gloriously; the horse and his rider he has thrown into the sea" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him" (v. 2).
3. "The LORD is a man of war; the LORD is his name" (v. 3).
4. "Who is like you, O LORD, among the gods? Who is like you, majestic in holiness, awesome in glorious deeds, doing wonders?" (v. 11).
5. "You have led in your steadfast love the people whom you have redeemed; you have guided them by your strength to your holy abode" (v. 13).

6. The nations will tremble (vv. 14-16), and God will plant his people "on your own mountain, the place, O LORD, which you have made for your abode" (v. 17).
7. "The LORD will reign forever and ever" (v. 18).
8. Miriam the prophetess takes a tambourine, and the women follow her with dancing, singing, "Sing to the LORD, for he has triumphed gloriously" (vv. 20-21).
9. After three days in the wilderness without water, they come to Marah, where the water is bitter, and the people grumble (vv. 22-24).
10. The LORD shows Moses a tree, which makes the water sweet. He tells Israel, "I am the LORD, your healer" (vv. 25-26). At Elim they find twelve springs and seventy palm trees (v. 27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The song is organized in three movements. The first (vv. 1-5) is a retelling of the victory at the sea. The second (vv. 6-12) praises God's power and holiness. The third (vv. 13-18) looks forward to the journey to the land and God's eternal reign. It is a poem of memory and hope.

The central line is in verse 2: "The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation." This verse will be quoted by Isaiah (12:2) and the Psalms (118:14). The word for "salvation" is yeshuah, the root of the name Jesus. The song is already pointing toward a greater salvation. Note too that the song is personal. "My strength...my God." The people have moved from asking Moses what he has done to them, to saying, "This is my God."

Verse 11 asks a rhetorical question that has an obvious answer: "Who is like you, O LORD, among the gods?" No one. The exodus is the demonstration that the God of Israel is not just a tribal deity but the Lord of the whole world. And he is "majestic in holiness." The song does not separate his power from his holiness. The God who defeats Pharaoh is the God whose character is pure.

The third movement is the one that people sometimes overlook. The song looks ahead: "You have led in your steadfast love the people whom you have redeemed." The tense is past, but the sentence is about the future, because the poet is so certain that God will finish what he has started that he speaks as though it is done. "You will bring them in and plant them." God's purpose is a place where he dwells with his people. The final line is a confession that carries the whole Bible forward: "The LORD will reign forever and ever."

Then comes the cold shower. In three days, the people are grumbling. The song has hardly died away. Marah, the bitter water, is the first test, and the people fail. God does not rebuke them but provides the tree. It is a lesson that he is the one who heals. The promise of verse 26

sets up the whole covenant: if they will listen to the LORD, they will not suffer as Egypt did. God's grace comes first, and then his commands.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 15:3 describes the redeemed standing by the sea of glass "and singing the song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb." Isaiah 12:2 quotes verse 2. Paul sings the theme in Ephesians 5:19: "singing and making melody to the Lord with your heart." The tree that made the water sweet has been compared by many to the cross, which turns the bitterness of death into life.

STEP 6

Application

Sing this week. Even if you do not consider yourself a singer, find a hymn or song about what God has done for you, and sing it aloud.

Look at your own wilderness. Where is there a Marah, a place of bitterness? Ask God to show you the tree.

Notice the speed with which gratitude fades. Write down three things God has done for you recently, and thank him for them before the end of the day.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Sing or speak to God of what he has done for you, in your own words.

Ask him to heal what is bitter in your life.

Confess how quickly you forget, and ask him to teach you to sing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 16

"The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him."

EXODUS 15:2

DAY 107 · WEEK 16

Psalm 77

I cry aloud to God; I remember your wonders of old

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 77. It begins in distress and ends with a picture of the exodus. Read it aloud, and notice the exact moment when the psalmist turns from his own trouble to God's past deeds.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 77 was written by Asaph, who also wrote Psalm 73. Like that one, it is the prayer of a person whose faith is shaken. But where Psalm 73 turned on the sanctuary, this psalm turns on memory. The psalmist faces a time of such trouble that he cannot sleep. And then he remembers the exodus, which you have just read. The psalm shows how the story of redemption is meant to be used: as a resource for hard days.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I cry aloud to God, aloud to God, and he will hear me" (v. 1).
2. "In the day of my trouble I seek the Lord; in the night my hand is stretched out without wearying; my soul refuses to be comforted" (v. 2).
3. "When I remember God, I am distressed; when I meditate, my spirit faints" (v. 3).
4. "You hold my eyelids open; I am so troubled that I cannot speak" (v. 4).
5. He asks a series of questions: "Will the Lord spurn forever…? Has his steadfast love forever ceased? Has God forgotten to be gracious?" (vv. 7-9).
6. Then, "I will appeal to this, to the years of the right hand of the Most High" (v. 10).
7. "I will remember the deeds of the LORD; yes, I will remember your wonders of old" (v. 11).

8. “Your way, O God, is holy. What god is great like our God? You are the God who works wonders” (vv. 13-14).

9. “With your arm you redeemed your people, the children of Jacob and Joseph” (v. 15).

10. “Your way was through the sea, your path through the great waters; yet your footprints were unseen” (v. 19). “You led your people like a flock by the hand of Moses and Aaron” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first nine verses of this psalm are a portrait of spiritual distress, and it is worth noticing what is unusual about it. “When I remember God, I am distressed.” You might expect that remembering God would be comforting. Here it is painful, because the psalmist remembers what God has been, and compares it to what he feels now. It is the distress of someone who believes in a good God and cannot reconcile that with his experience.

The questions of verses 7 to 9 are the real question at the heart of the psalm. Will the Lord reject forever? Has his steadfast love ceased? Has he forgotten? Each question is a way of asking whether the covenant is still good. And the psalmist does not answer them right away.

The turn comes in verse 10. “Then I said, I will appeal to this.” The Hebrew of this verse is difficult, and translations vary, but the sense is that the psalmist makes a decision. He will stop focusing on his feelings, and he will recall what God has done. “I will remember the deeds of the LORD.” This is a deliberate act of the will. He does not wait to feel like remembering.

What does he remember? The exodus. Verses 16 to 20 are a lyrical retelling of the crossing of the sea. The waters trembled. The depths shook. The clouds poured out water. God’s arrows and thunder flashed. The picture is of a storm, and God is at the center of it. And then the line that is the most striking of all: “Your way was through the sea…yet your footprints were unseen.” God’s way was through the sea, but you could not see his tracks. This is a profound description of providence. God was at work, with absolute power, but invisibly. There were no footprints.

That is the answer to the psalmist’s problem. His circumstances do not show God’s footprints, but that does not mean that God is not at work. The exodus proved that God can lead his people through impossible places without leaving a visible trace. And the psalm ends with the quiet image of a shepherd: “You led your people like a flock by the hand of Moses and Aaron.” He leads through human hands, and he leads like a shepherd.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul writes in Romans 11:33 about God's "paths beyond tracing out." Jesus asked his disciples to remember the feeding of the five thousand when they worried about bread (Mark 8:17-21). At the Lord's Supper, Jesus told his followers, "Do this in remembrance of me" (Luke 22:19). Psalm 77's pattern, of distress, then deliberate remembering, then worship, is also the pattern in Psalm 42 and Lamentations 3.

STEP 6

Application

When your feelings are overwhelming, remember on purpose. Write out a list of the deeds of the LORD in your life, and in the Bible. Read it aloud.

Think about a time you could not see God's footprints, and later saw that he had been working. Tell someone about it.

Take the Lord's Supper as an act of remembering, not only as a ritual.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry out to God, and tell him where your soul refuses to be comforted.
- Remember aloud a deed of God that you can hold on to.
- Thank him that he leads you even when you cannot see his footprints.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 16

"The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him."

EXODUS 15:2

DAY 108 · WEEK 16

Psalm 114

When Israel went out of Egypt, the sea fled

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 114. It has only eight verses, and it is one of the most compressed poems in the Psalter. Read it twice, once as a celebration of the exodus and once as a call to tremble before God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the third psalm in a row that looks back at the exodus. Psalm 106 was a confession, Psalm 77 was a memory in distress, and Psalm 114 is a burst of joy. It is part of the "Egyptian Hallel," Psalms 113 to 118, which Jewish families have sung at the Passover meal for centuries. It was probably among the songs that Jesus and his disciples sang after the Last Supper (Mark 14:26). In just a few lines, it tells the whole story of redemption through the language of nature responding to God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When Israel went out from Egypt, the house of Jacob from a people of strange language" (v. 1).
2. "Judah became his sanctuary, Israel his dominion" (v. 2).
3. "The sea looked and fled; Jordan turned back" (v. 3).
4. "The mountains skipped like rams, the hills like lambs" (v. 4).
5. The psalmist asks the sea, the Jordan, and the mountains what is wrong with them (vv. 5-6).
6. "Tremble, O earth, at the presence of the Lord, at the presence of the God of Jacob" (v. 7).

7. “Who turns the rock into a pool of water, the flint into a spring of water” (v. 8).

8. The psalm has two halves: verses 1 to 4 describe what happened, and verses 5 to 8 call the earth to respond.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm does something unusual. It tells the story of the exodus without ever naming God until verse 7. The whole description is of Israel and the world’s reaction. The sea flees. The river turns back. The mountains leap. The poet leaves God offstage in order to make you feel his presence, like seeing the effect of a hurricane without the storm.

Verse 2 contains the heart of the exodus: “Judah became his sanctuary, Israel his dominion.” God did not just free Israel. He claimed them. They were redeemed to be his dwelling place and his kingdom. This is the purpose of the exodus: not just freedom from but freedom for. It is the same as the promise in Exodus 6:7: “I will take you to be my people, and I will be your God.”

The questions of verses 5 and 6 are a bit of poetic humor. The poet asks the sea, “What is wrong with you?” The answer is not stated, but it is obvious: the Lord is here. Creation is not a neutral stage. It is a servant of God, and when he moves, it responds. The sea and the river, which seemed so powerful to ancient people, flee at his command.

The last verse is the most wonderful. After the earth trembles, the God who made it “turns the rock into a pool of water.” He is not only the one who shakes mountains. He is also the one who turns hard stone into fresh water for thirsty people. The God of power is also the God of provision, and you will see this very story in tomorrow’s reading at Massah and Meribah. The same hand does both.

The progression of the psalm is worth noticing. It begins with a historic event. It moves to the response of nature. And it ends with a command to the whole earth to tremble before the presence of the Lord. This is what the exodus is meant to do. It is not just a story about the past. It is a call to every creature to recognize who God is.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul writes that Christ is “the rock” that followed Israel (1 Corinthians 10:4). Jesus said that he is the source of “living water” (John 4:14; 7:37-38). At Jesus’ death, the earth shook and the rocks were split (Matthew 27:51), and creation responded again to its Lord. Isaiah 44:3 and 48:21 also describe God providing water from the rock.

STEP 6

Application

Spend a few minutes outside this week, and notice the creation around you as a servant of God. Thank him for the rain, the rivers, and the hills.

Ask yourself if you tremble before the Lord, or if you have grown casual. Ask him to restore a healthy sense of awe.

Thank Jesus for being the rock from which living water flows.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tremble and rejoice before God, as the earth does.

Thank him for Jesus, who gives living water.

Tell him what you want to bring out of "Egypt" in your own life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 16

"The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him."

EXODUS 15:2

DAY 109 · WEEK 16

Exodus 16:1-18:27

Manna, quail, water from the rock, God provides

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 16:1-18:27. These chapters take Israel from the Red Sea toward Sinai. Read them as three tests: hunger in chapter 16, thirst and war in chapter 17, and leadership in chapter 18. Watch for the way God provides each time.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel is now six weeks out of Egypt, and the food they carried is gone. The wilderness is not a good place to feed millions of people. The next three chapters show what the first stages of life with God are like, and they are not easy. The people grumble. God answers with generosity. This is a school of dependence, and the lesson is that the God who redeemed them is the God who will provide for them every day.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The people complain: “Would that we had died by the hand of the LORD in the land of Egypt, when we sat by the meat pots and ate bread to the full” (16:3).
2. God says, “Behold, I am about to rain bread from heaven for you” (16:4), and it is to test whether they will walk in his law.
3. In the morning, there is a fine, flake-like thing on the ground. They say, “What is it?” and Moses answers, “It is the bread that the LORD has given you to eat” (16:14-15). They call it manna.
4. Each person gathers as much as they need, “and whoever gathered much had nothing left over, and whoever gathered little had no lack” (16:18).
5. Those who keep it overnight find it full of worms and foul, except on the sixth day, when a double portion is given for the Sabbath (16:19-26).

6. At Massah and Meribah, the people quarrel with Moses for water. They ask, "Is the LORD among us or not?" (17:7).
7. God tells Moses to strike the rock at Horeb, and water comes out (17:5-6).
8. Amalek attacks. Joshua fights, and as long as Moses holds up his hands, Israel prevails, with Aaron and Hur holding them up (17:8-13).
9. Moses builds an altar and calls it "The LORD Is My Banner" (17:15).
10. Moses' father-in-law, Jethro, visits, and says, "Now I know that the LORD is greater than all gods" (18:11). He advises Moses to appoint judges to share the work (18:13-27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to see is how quickly the people go from song to complaint. It has been less than two months since they sang at the Red Sea. Now they say they wish they had died in Egypt. It is a ridiculous and also very human response. When life is hard, we tend to remember the past through rose-colored glasses. They forget the slavery and remember the meat pots.

God's response is gracious. He does not strike them down. He gives them bread from heaven. But he adds an important detail: it is a test. "That I may test them, whether they will walk in my law or not." The test is about daily dependence. They are to gather only what they need for the day. If they try to store it up, it spoils. The only exception is the sixth day, when they receive a double portion. This teaches them two lessons at once: trust God for tomorrow, and rest on the Sabbath. It also shows the connection between provision and rest, a link between the gift of food and the gift of the Sabbath that anticipates the commandments to come.

Moses later explains the purpose: "Man does not live by bread alone, but man lives by every word that comes from the mouth of the LORD" (Deuteronomy 8:3). The manna was a daily reminder that life comes from God's mouth.

At Massah and Meribah, the question is sharper: "Is the LORD among us or not?" It is the question that haunts the whole wilderness, and God answers it by giving water from the rock. The rock is struck once, and life flows from it.

The battle with Amalek is the first attack on Israel after the exodus, and the posture of Moses is the point. He stands with his hands raised, and when they fall, Israel loses. He needs help. Aaron and Hur support him. It is a picture of intercession, and the picture of a community that holds up its leaders. The victory is the LORD's, not Joshua's. That is why Moses names the altar, "The LORD is my banner."

Jethro's advice shows that God also works through ordinary wisdom. Moses is wearing himself out, and a foreign priest points out that the work must be shared. It is a reminder that good leadership means delegation and that humility is willing to receive counsel.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus says, "I am the bread of life" (John 6:35), and he contrasts himself with the manna: "Your fathers ate the manna in the wilderness, and they died. This is the bread that comes down from heaven, so that one may eat of it and not die" (John 6:49-50). Paul says the rock was Christ (1 Corinthians 10:4). Jesus teaches us to pray, "Give us this day our daily bread" (Matthew 6:11). Hebrews 7:25 says Christ "always lives to make intercession" for his people.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for daily bread, and practice depending on God for each day. Resist the urge to store up anxiety about the future.

When you find yourself asking, "Is the LORD among us or not?", answer with what you know of him.

Ask who is holding up your hands, and whose hands you could hold up. Make a plan to encourage a pastor or a leader this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God for your daily bread, and tell him what worries you about tomorrow.
- Thank him for Jesus, the bread of life.
- Ask him to teach you to depend on him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 16

"The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him."

EXODUS 15:2

DAY 110 · WEEK 16

Exodus 19:1-20:26

Sinai; the Ten Commandments, law after redemption

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 19:1-20:26. This is Mount Sinai, the giving of the Ten Commandments. Pay close attention to the order: first God describes what he has done, then he describes who they are, and only then does he give the commandments.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Three months after leaving Egypt, Israel arrives at Mount Sinai. It is the turning point of the whole book. Everything before this point was rescue. Everything after is covenant, the formal relationship between God and Israel. The next several chapters are among the most important in the Old Testament, because they set out the terms of the Mosaic covenant. At the center is the Decalogue, the Ten Commandments. This is the day to remember that God redeems before he commands.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God says through Moses, “You yourselves have seen what I did to the Egyptians, and how I bore you on eagles” wings and brought you to myself’ (19:4).
2. “Now therefore, if you will indeed obey my voice and keep my covenant, you shall be my treasured possession among all peoples, for all the earth is mine” (19:5).
3. “And you shall be to me a kingdom of priests and a holy nation” (19:6).
4. The people answer together, “All that the LORD has spoken we will do” (19:8).
5. The people are consecrated, and boundaries are set around the mountain (19:10-13).
6. On the third day, there is thunder and lightning, a thick cloud, and a loud trumpet blast. “Mount Sinai was wrapped in smoke because the LORD had descended on it in fire”

(19:16-18).

7. God speaks: "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery" (20:2).

8. The commandments: no other gods; no carved images; do not take the LORD's name in vain; remember the Sabbath; honor your father and mother; do not murder, commit adultery, steal, bear false witness, or covet (20:3-17).

9. The people tremble and say to Moses, "You speak to us, and we will hear; but do not let God speak to us, lest we die" (20:19).

10. Moses says, "Do not fear, for God has come to test you, that the fear of him may be before you, that you may not sin" (20:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Look at the order. In chapter 19, before a single commandment is given, God reminds Israel of what he has done: "You have seen…how I bore you on eagles' wings and brought you to myself.' The same pattern is in 20:2. The commandments begin with a statement of redemption, "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery." This is the key to the entire law. It is not a ladder by which slaves climb to freedom. It is the way of life for people who have already been freed. This is the pattern of grace establishing law, and it is the theme of the unit.

God's description of Israel in 19:5-6 is breathtaking. "My treasured possession." "A kingdom of priests and a holy nation." They are chosen out of all the peoples, set apart, and given a mission. They are to be priests, mediating between God and the nations. The New Testament will apply this same language to the church (1 Peter 2:9).

The people respond with eagerness: "All that the LORD has spoken we will do." It is a sincere answer, and it is a disastrously overconfident one. They have not yet understood what they promised. Within forty days they will be dancing around a golden calf. It is one of the key tragedies of the Old Testament: the people said yes without understanding the cost.

The scene at the mountain is meant to communicate holiness. The boundaries, the fire, the smoke, the thunder, and the trumpet all say the same thing: God is not safe. The people are frightened, and rightly so. Their request that Moses speak for them is a request for a mediator. God approves it in Deuteronomy 18:17. A mediator will stand between them and the holy God. This points forward to Christ.

The Ten Commandments themselves are a summary of what it means to love God and love your neighbor. The first four concern God: his exclusive worship, his image, his name, and his day. The last six concern people: family, life, marriage, property, truth, and the heart's desire. The tenth, "You shall not covet," is the one that goes deepest, because it is about what the heart wants, and no human court can enforce it.

Moses' last word at the end of the chapter is a paradox. "Do not fear...that the fear of him may be before you." There is a fear that is terror, and a fear that is reverence. God does not want his people to cower. He wants them to stand in awe.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus summarized the law as love for God and love for neighbor (Matthew 22:37-40). Hebrews 12:18-24 contrasts Mount Sinai, the mountain of fear, with Mount Zion, where we come to "Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant." Peter calls the church "a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession" (1 Peter 2:9). Paul says that the law was "added because of transgressions" (Galatians 3:19), pointing to Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Say the Ten Commandments aloud, or read them slowly, and ask which one most clearly shows your need of grace. Do not rush through this step.

Notice that the first words are not "You shall" but "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out." Receive that sentence as a statement about you if you are in Christ.

Think about how you tend to say "all that the LORD has spoken we will do" without counting the cost. Ask God for a humble and honest heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he redeems before he commands.

Tell him where you find his commands hard.

Thank Jesus for keeping the law you could not.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 16

"The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him."

EXODUS 15:2

DAY 111 · WEEK 16

Exodus 20:1-17; Matthew 5:17-48; Romans 13:8-10

The Moral Law and the Christian

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 20:1-17, Matthew 5:17-48, and Romans 13:8-10. The first is the Ten Commandments, the second is Jesus' teaching about the law in the Sermon on the Mount, and the third is Paul's summary of the law as love. Read them in order, and ask how each one relates to the others.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second doctrinal pause in Unit 5, and it raises one of the most important questions in the Christian life: what is the place of the law for someone who is saved by grace? Christians have debated this for two thousand years. Some say that Christ has abolished the law. Others say that it applies to us just as it did to Israel. The answer, as usual, is in between, and it takes careful reading. You are not under the law as a way of earning salvation, and yet the law still matters. This day will help you see how.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The Ten Commandments begin with grace: "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt" (Exodus 20:2).
2. Jesus says, "Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them" (Matthew 5:17).
3. "Until heaven and earth pass away, not an iota or a dot will pass from the Law until all is accomplished" (5:18).
4. Jesus teaches six times, "You have heard that it was said…But I say to you" (5:21, 27, 31, 33, 38, 43).

5. On murder: “Everyone who is angry with his brother will be liable to judgment” (5:22). On adultery: “Everyone who looks at a woman with lustful intent has already committed adultery with her in his heart” (5:28).
6. He ends: “You therefore must be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect” (5:48).
7. Paul writes, “Owe no one anything, except to love each other, for the one who loves another has fulfilled the law” (Romans 13:8).
8. The commandments “are summed up in this word: You shall love your neighbor as yourself” (13:9). “Love is the fulfilling of the law” (13:10).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Christians have long spoken of three uses of the law, a framework that goes back to the Reformation. The first use is civil or political. The law restrains evil in society by setting boundaries and threatening punishment. Paul says that the law is “not laid down for the just but for the lawless and disobedient” (1 Timothy 1:9). The second use is pedagogical, or evangelical. The law shows us our sin and drives us to Christ. Paul writes, “Through the law comes knowledge of sin” (Romans 3:20), and “the law was our guardian until Christ came, in order that we might be justified by faith” (Galatians 3:24). The third use is for believers: the law shows what a life that pleases God looks like. It guides the redeemed to live as the redeemed.

You can see all three at work in Exodus 19 and 20. The commandments restrain a violent and idolatrous people. They also expose sin, as the people’s quick fall into idolatry proves. And they tell a freed people how to live as God’s people. All three uses are present.

How does this fit with the New Testament? Here the Bible’s own storyline matters. The law given at Sinai was a covenant with Israel, with its own sanctions, rituals, and civil laws. The New Testament teaches that Christians are no longer “under the law” in that sense (Romans 6:14; Galatians 3:25). The Mosaic covenant, as a covenant, has been fulfilled and replaced by the new covenant (Hebrews 8:13). This means that we do not keep the sacrificial system, the food laws, or the civil code of ancient Israel. They pointed to Christ, and he has accomplished what they signified.

But this does not mean that the moral will of God has changed. Jesus says that he came to fulfill the law, not to abolish it. He fulfilled it in several ways: by obeying it perfectly, by bearing its penalty, by fulfilling what it pointed to, and by revealing its deepest meaning. In the Sermon on the Mount, he shows that the commandments reach the heart: not just murder but anger, not just adultery but lust. The moral core of the Ten Commandments is

reaffirmed in the New Testament, though now seen in the light of Christ, and nine of the ten are repeated explicitly (the fourth, about the Sabbath, is applied in a distinctive way through the rest we have in Christ, as in Hebrews 4:9-10 and Colossians 2:16-17).

The new covenant also gives something the old could not: a new heart. Jeremiah promised, "I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts" (Jeremiah 31:33). This is the power of the Spirit. The law still shows us what God desires, but now the Spirit enables us to love it. Paul calls this "the law of Christ" (Galatians 6:2), the law of love as lived and taught by Jesus.

That is why Paul can say in Romans 13 that love fulfills the law. He does not mean that love replaces the commandments. He means that love is what the commandments were pointing to all along. If you love your neighbor, you will not murder, steal, or covet. The law is not a list of rules to be checked. It is a description of what love does.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Pay attention to what Jesus does in Matthew 5. He does not loosen the law. He tightens it. Anger is a kind of murder. Lust is a kind of adultery. This is not meant to crush his hearers into despair, though it does that for anyone honest. It is meant to show that the standard is perfection, "as your heavenly Father is perfect." No one can meet that standard. The law is a mirror that shows us what we are.

But this is where the good news comes in. If you cannot keep the law, you need someone who has. Jesus lived a life of perfect obedience, and he gives it to those who trust in him. In 2 Corinthians 5:21, Paul says, "For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God." Our standing before God is based on his obedience, not ours.

And once you are in Christ, the law takes on a new character. It is no longer a threat. It is a guide. It describes the kind of life that the Spirit is producing in you. This is why Paul can say both that we are not under the law and that we fulfill its requirement (Romans 8:4). The one who is saved by grace wants to obey.

The structure of Exodus 20 should be remembered. Grace comes first: "I brought you out." Then law: "You shall." This is the order of the gospel. We obey because we have been saved, not in order to be saved.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:3-4 says that “God has done what the law, weakened by the flesh, could not do…in order that the righteous requirement of the law might be fulfilled in us, who walk not according to the flesh but according to the Spirit.” Galatians 5:14 says, “For the whole law is fulfilled in one word: You shall love your neighbor as yourself.” James 2:8-12 calls it “the royal law” and “the law of liberty.” Hebrews 8:10 quotes Jeremiah 31 about the law written on the heart.

STEP 6

Application

Read the Sermon on the Mount slowly this week. Ask the Spirit to show you where your heart does not match the standard, and bring that to Christ.

Choose one commandment to meditate on, and ask how a person who loves God and neighbor would keep it in your situation this week.

Thank God for the new heart he has given you, and ask him to increase your delight in his commands.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that the law shows your need and drives you to Christ.
- Ask the Spirit to write his law on your heart.
- Ask for a love for God and neighbor that comes from the heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 16

“The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father’s God, and I will exalt him.”

EXODUS 15:2

DAY 112 · WEEK 16

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Exodus 15:2 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him."

EXODUS 15:2

REST

Meditation

Exodus 15:2 is the first personal confession of faith in the Bible's story of redemption. It comes from the lips of a freed people standing on the shore of the sea, and it is as true today as it was then.

"The LORD is my strength." They have just seen what happened when they tried to rely on their own strength in Egypt: nothing. Now they have seen what he can do. Notice the possessive: not "the LORD is strong" but "the LORD is my strength." The strength of God becomes the strength of his people. When you are weak, as you often are, this is your resource.

"And my song." This is one of the loveliest phrases in Scripture. God is not only the source of strength but the reason for singing. A person who has been rescued does not just survive. They sing. If you find yourself without a song, one remedy is to remember what he has done.

“And he has become my salvation.” This is the center. The word is yeshuah, the root of the name Jesus. God himself is the salvation. He is not just the one who gives a rescue. He is the rescue. The same is true of Jesus: he does not merely point to a way of salvation. He is the way.

“This is my God, and I will praise him.” Faith is personal. It is not enough to know about God. The goal is to say “my God.” “My father’s God, and I will exalt him.” And faith is generational. The God of the fathers has become the God of the children.

For the Christian, the verse is a daily prayer. In Christ, the LORD is your strength, your song, and your salvation.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw the exodus completed and the journey to Sinai begun. You read Moses’ song, the first song of redemption, and then watched the people turn to complaining at Marah. You prayed three psalms about the exodus: Psalm 77, where the psalmist remembered the deeds of God in his distress, and Psalm 114, where the earth trembled before the God who brought Israel out. You followed Israel through hunger and the gift of manna, through thirst and water from the rock, and through the battle with Amalek, where Moses’ hands were held up by Aaron and Hur. Then you came to Sinai. You heard God describe Israel as a kingdom of priests and a holy nation, and you read the Ten Commandments, which begin with the words, “I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt.” On the doctrinal day, you considered the three uses of the law and how the law relates to the Christian. The week taught that God redeems before he commands, and that the law shows us our need for grace.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Moses sang, “The LORD is my strength and my song.” What is the song you are singing right now? If you are in a season without a song, what would it take to remember what God has done?

How does it change your reading of the Ten Commandments to know that they begin with “I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt”? How does Christ’s fulfillment of the law affect the way you obey it?

Think of a time when you asked, “Is the LORD among us or not?” How did God answer? Write about how he has shown himself to be present with you, and thank him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he redeems before he commands.

Thank Christ for fulfilling the law for you.

Rest in him, and ask him to teach you to love his commandments.

DAY 113 · WEEK 17

Exodus 21:1-22:31

The Book of the Covenant, case laws

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 55 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 21:1-22:31. These two chapters contain the first set of laws that follow the Ten Commandments. They can feel foreign and sometimes hard. Read them slowly, and ask what each law shows about God's concern for justice, for the vulnerable, and for human life.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the Ten Commandments, God gives Moses a long set of specific rulings called the Book of the Covenant (Exodus 20:22-23:33). They are case laws, applications of the broad principles of the Ten Commandments to the daily life of an agricultural society in the ancient Near East. This is not the part of the Bible that most new readers enjoy. But it is worth reading carefully, because it shows how God cares about the details of everyday justice. The laws also come to us in a particular covenant with Israel at a particular time, and reading them well means knowing how they fit the whole story.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The first law concerns Hebrew servants: "When you buy a Hebrew slave, he shall serve six years, and in the seventh he shall go out free, for nothing" (21:2).
2. Kidnapping is a capital crime: "Whoever steals a man and sells him, and anyone found in possession of him, shall be put to death" (21:16).
3. Laws on injury include the principle, "You shall pay life for life, eye for eye, tooth for tooth, hand for hand, foot for foot" (21:23-24).
4. If a slave is injured by a master, the slave is to go free (21:26-27).

5. If an ox gores someone, the owner is held responsible if he knew it was dangerous (21:28-36).
6. Laws on theft and restitution require thieves to repay several times over (22:1-4).
7. "You shall not wrong a sojourner or oppress him, for you were sojourners in the land of Egypt" (22:21).
8. "You shall not afflict any widow or fatherless child. If you do afflict them…my wrath will burn" (22:22-24).
9. "If you lend money to my people, to the poor among you, you shall not be to him as a moneylender, and you shall not exact interest from him" (22:25).
10. "If ever you take your neighbor's cloak in pledge, you shall return it to him before the sun goes down…for when he cries to me, I will hear, for I am compassionate" (22:26-27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to understand is the way these laws are written. They are case laws: "If a man does this, then this is the consequence." They are not an exhaustive legal code. They are examples that train judges to think about justice. The laws are also specific to the setting of ancient Israel. Modern readers sometimes want to treat every verse as a rule for today, or else dismiss the whole thing as irrelevant. Neither is right. The better approach is to ask what each law reveals about God's character, and how the principle is fulfilled in Christ.

Take the opening law about servants. It may trouble modern readers, and the questions are fair. Slavery is a hard subject, and the Bible does not hide from it. But look at what the law actually does. The servitude it describes is a form of debt labor, limited to six years, with release in the seventh. Kidnapping and selling a person is punished by death. Injury to a slave sets the slave free. In a world where slaves were property without rights, the law gives human beings dignity and protection. It does not describe the ideal. It restrains the worst. The deeper message, "You were sojourners in Egypt," appeals to the exodus. Israel is to remember that they were slaves once, and that the LORD set them free.

The "eye for eye" principle is easy to misread. In its original setting, it is a limit, not a license for revenge. The punishment must fit the crime and go no further. This protects against escalating retaliation. Jesus will take the principle deeper in Matthew 5:38-39, telling his followers to renounce personal revenge: "If anyone slaps you on the right cheek, turn to him the other also." He is not abolishing the court's duty to do justice. He is calling individuals to a higher way of living.

The most striking pattern in these chapters is the care for the weak. The sojourner, the widow, the orphan, and the poor borrower are all named. God says that when they cry out, "I will surely hear their cry" (22:23). The God who heard the cry of Israel in Egypt now commands Israel to hear the cry of the vulnerable. His justice is shaped by his own experience of redeeming slaves. The cloak law is a gem: a poor man's coat, taken as a pledge, must be returned by nightfall, because he needs it to sleep in. And the reason given is simply: "for I am compassionate."

Paul shows how to read these laws in light of Christ in 1 Corinthians 9:9-10. He quotes the law, "You shall not muzzle an ox when it treads out the grain," and applies it to paying ministers. He sees in the law a principle of fairness that goes beyond the particular case. We are to read the case laws as windows into the heart of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said that the greatest in the kingdom would be the servant of all (Mark 10:43-45). Paul's letter to Philemon asks a master to receive his runaway slave "no longer as a bondservant but more than a bondservant, as a beloved brother" (Philemon 16). James 1:27 says that "religion that is pure and undefiled before God" is "to visit orphans and widows in their affliction." Leviticus 19:33-34 repeats the command to love the sojourner.

STEP 6

Application

Read the laws on the vulnerable in 22:21-27 again. Who are the sojourners, widows, orphans, and poor borrowers in your community? Choose one action this week to help one of them.

Practice reading hard passages by asking what they reveal about God's character. Write down one thing you learn about God from today's reading.

Thank God that he is compassionate, and let that shape the way you treat people who owe you something.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to give you his heart for the stranger, the widow, and the orphan.

Ask him for humility as you read his law.

Tell him where you are asking Christ to show you more.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 17

"And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst."

EXODUS 25:8

DAY 114 · WEEK 17

Exodus 23:1-24:18

Covenant concluded; the Sabbath; ratification with blood

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 23:1-24:18. The first part finishes the Book of the Covenant with laws on justice, the Sabbath, and the feasts. The second part, chapter 24, describes the ratification of the covenant with blood. Read chapter 24 slowly. It is one of the most important chapters in the Old Testament.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The laws of the Book of the Covenant are almost finished. Now Moses goes down to the people, and the covenant between God and Israel is formally sealed. This is like a wedding ceremony or a treaty ratification. There is a reading of the terms, a public promise by the people, a sacrifice, and a meal. Then Moses is called back up the mountain for forty days to receive instructions for the tabernacle. This is the end of the first half of Exodus, and the unit's closing scene.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You shall not fall in with the many to do wrong, nor shall you bear witness in a lawsuit, siding with the many, so as to pervert justice" (23:2).
2. "If you meet your enemy's ox or his donkey going astray, you shall bring it back to him" (23:4).
3. "You shall not oppress a sojourner. You know the heart of a sojourner, for you were sojourners in the land of Egypt" (23:9).
4. "Six days you shall do your work, but on the seventh day you shall rest" (23:12). The land too is to rest every seventh year (23:10-11).

5. Three times a year, all males are to appear before the LORD at the feasts of unleavened bread, harvest, and ingathering (23:14-17).
6. God promises to send an angel before them, "for my name is in him" (23:20-21).
7. Moses writes down all the words of the LORD and builds an altar with twelve pillars. The people say, "All that the LORD has spoken we will do, and we will be obedient" (24:3-7).
8. Moses takes half the blood and throws it against the altar, and the other half he sprinkles on the people, saying, "Behold the blood of the covenant that the LORD has made with you in accordance with all these words" (24:6-8).
9. Moses, Aaron, Nadab, Abihu, and seventy elders go up and "saw the God of Israel…they beheld God, and ate and drank" (24:9-11).
10. Moses goes up the mountain with Joshua, and the glory of the LORD rests on it like "a devouring fire" for forty days and forty nights (24:13-18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The laws at the start of chapter 23 are some of the most practical in the Bible. They tell the truth in court, even when the crowd is against you. They tell you to help an enemy's animal in trouble. They forbid taking bribes. The standards are high and they touch real life. The line "You shall not fall in with the many to do wrong" is a good motto for a believer in any age. The right thing and the popular thing are not always the same.

Most striking is the repeated appeal to Israel's own experience. "You know the heart of a sojourner." The law is built on empathy: you have been where they are, so treat them as God treated you. This is the way the Bible teaches ethics. It asks people to remember grace and then to act like people who have received it.

Now to chapter 24, which is the most significant. The covenant is sealed with blood. This is the second great blood ritual in the book, after the Passover. At the Passover, the blood protected Israel from judgment. Here, the blood binds Israel to God in covenant. Half is thrown on the altar, which represents God, and half is sprinkled on the people. Both parties are bound together by the blood. "Behold the blood of the covenant." These are words that Jesus will echo at the Last Supper.

The promise of the people, "All that the LORD has spoken we will do, and we will be obedient," is sincere. But as you saw earlier, they will break it within weeks. The covenant is real, and the people are weak. This tension, between God's holy demands and human

inability, runs through the whole Old Testament and creates the longing for a better covenant.

The scene on the mountain in verses 9 to 11 is one of the most mysterious in the Bible. Leaders of Israel see the God of Israel. They see "under his feet as it were a pavement of sapphire stone, like the very heaven for clearness." It is a glimpse of the throne room of God. And, astonishingly, "God did not lay his hand on them. They beheld God, and ate and drank." They share a meal in his presence. This is a preview of the fellowship that is the goal of the covenant, and it will be fulfilled when God's people eat and drink with him in the kingdom.

The unit ends with Moses entering the cloud. The glory looks like a devouring fire. God is both near and dangerous, and Moses will be gone for forty days.

STEP 5

Connection

At the Last Supper, Jesus took the cup and said, "This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins" (Matthew 26:28), echoing Exodus 24:8. Hebrews 9:18-22 explains that the first covenant was inaugurated with blood and that Christ's blood inaugurates a better one. The meal on the mountain points to the marriage supper of the Lamb (Revelation 19:9). Peter says that believers are "sprinkled with his blood" (1 Peter 1:2).

STEP 6

Application

When you take the Lord's Supper, hear the words of Exodus 24:8 behind the words of Jesus. You are being brought into a covenant sealed with blood.

Think about where you tend to "fall in with the many." Ask God for courage to stand for what is right.

Remember what it was like to be a stranger or an outsider in a new church, a new job, or a new town. Reach out to someone who is new this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for the blood that sealed the covenant for you.

Ask for courage to do right when the crowd does wrong.

Ask him to teach you kindness to strangers.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 17

"And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst."

EXODUS 25:8

DAY 115 · WEEK 17

Psalm 105:26-45

Moses and Aaron sent; the plagues recounted

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 105:26-45. This is the exodus story told as praise. Compare it in your mind to Psalm 106, which you read earlier in the unit. The two psalms tell the same history from opposite sides.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 105 and Psalm 106 are a pair. Psalm 106 tells the story of Israel's failures. Psalm 105 tells the story of God's faithfulness. This psalm begins by calling Israel to thank the LORD and make his deeds known among the peoples, and then it traces the history from Abraham to the conquest. Today you read the section about the exodus, and it is a fitting way to end Unit 5, since it summarizes everything you have just read and gives the reason for it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He sent Moses his servant, and Aaron, whom he had chosen" (v. 26).
2. "They performed his signs among them and miracles in the land of Ham" (v. 27).
3. The plagues are recounted: darkness, blood, frogs, flies, gnats, hail, locusts, and the death of the firstborn (vv. 28-36).
4. "Then he brought out Israel with silver and gold, and there was none among his tribes who stumbled" (v. 37).
5. "Egypt was glad when they departed, for dread of them had fallen upon it" (v. 38).
6. "He spread a cloud for a covering, and fire to give light by night" (v. 39).
7. "They asked, and he brought quail, and gave them bread from heaven in abundance" (v. 40).

8. “He opened the rock, and water gushed out; it flowed through the desert like a river” (v. 41).
9. “For he remembered his holy promise, and Abraham, his servant” (v. 42).
10. “So he brought his people out with joy, his chosen ones with singing” (v. 43).
11. He gave them the lands of the nations “that they might keep his statutes and observe his laws. Praise the LORD!” (vv. 44-45).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 105 is a retelling of the exodus with all the failures left out. This is not dishonest. It is a different purpose. Psalm 106 is a confession. Psalm 105 is a thanksgiving. Both are true. The Bible does not hide Israel’s sin, and it does not let sin have the last word.

Notice first who the main actor is. “He sent Moses.” “He brought out Israel.” “He spread a cloud.” “He brought quail.” “He opened the rock.” In the whole passage, God is the subject of almost every verb. Israel is the object. The psalmist is retelling the exodus as a story of what God did. That is the right way to read it. The story is not primarily about Moses’ courage or Israel’s faith. It is about God’s power and faithfulness.

The reason is given in verse 42: “For he remembered his holy promise, and Abraham, his servant.” This verse is the key to the whole book of Exodus. In 2:24, God heard their groaning and remembered his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Here, centuries later, the psalmist says the same: he remembered. The exodus was not a rescue of convenience. It was the fulfillment of a promise made generations before.

Verse 37 is a nice detail. “There was none among his tribes who stumbled.” The whole company of Israel, old, young, sick, and weak, walked out of Egypt without anyone falling behind. God’s redemption is complete. No one is lost.

The ending sets out the purpose of the entire exodus. God gave them the land “that they might keep his statutes and observe his laws.” This brings you back to Sinai. The goal of redemption is a people who obey. This is not to earn the redemption but to live as the redeemed. And the response to all of it is the one word that closes the psalm: “Praise the LORD!”

Placed here, at the end of the unit, the psalm looks forward as well. The God who remembered Abraham and kept his word to Israel will remember his covenant again and send a greater redeemer.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 1:72-73 sings the same note at the birth of Jesus: God "has remembered his holy covenant, the oath that he swore to our father Abraham." Peter says that Christ's death was foreknown and planned (1 Peter 1:18-20). Hebrews 2:15 says Christ came "to deliver all those who through fear of death were subject to lifelong slavery." Revelation 15 and 16 echo the plagues and the song of Moses.

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of ways God has been faithful to a promise in your life or in the life of your church. Praise him for each one.

Notice how the psalm ends with obedience. Ask what a response of gratitude would look like in your daily choices.

Say the last word of the psalm out loud: "Praise the LORD!" Do it at least once today, on purpose.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for being faithful to every word he has spoken.
- Thank him for the greater exodus in Jesus.
- Ask him to help you keep his statutes out of gratitude.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 17

"And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst."

EXODUS 25:8

DAY 116 · WEEK 17

Review and Reflection

Unit 5 review, The Mosaic Covenant I, Exodus

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery."
>
> EXODUS 20:2

REST

Meditation

Exodus 20:2 is the opening line of the Ten Commandments, and it is the unit's anchor verse. It is easy to skip over it on the way to the commands, but it is the most important sentence in the chapter. Read it aloud once more before you continue.

"I am the LORD your God." The sentence begins with a name and a relationship. God is the LORD, the covenant God who revealed himself at the burning bush. And he is "your God." Before there is any command, there is a claim: I belong to you, and you belong to me.

"Who brought you out of the land of Egypt." This is the basis of the claim. God has already acted. He rescued them when they could not rescue themselves. The authority of the commandments rests on his grace.

"Out of the house of slavery." It is a wonderful phrase. Egypt was a house, a place of confinement and hard labor, and God brought them out. The rest of the commandments describe what life looks like for people who have been freed. They are no longer slaves, so they do not need to act like slaves, and they are no longer under Pharaoh, so they do not serve other gods.

For the Christian, the verse is a statement about Christ. He is the one who has brought us out of the house of slavery, the slavery to sin and death. "For freedom Christ has set us free" (Galatians 5:1). Obedience is the grateful response of those who have been rescued.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 5 you have read the first half of the book of Exodus, from the birth of Moses to the ratification of the covenant at Sinai. You began with Israel in slavery and with Pharaoh's attempt to destroy the Hebrew sons, and you watched God preserve a baby in a basket. At the burning bush, God revealed his name, I AM WHO I AM, and sent a reluctant Moses to bring his people out. On your first doctrinal day, you studied the existence and attributes of God, from his self-existence to the character of mercy and justice that he proclaimed in Exodus 34.

You followed the confrontation with Pharaoh. The plagues, one after another, were judgments on the gods of Egypt and demonstrations of who the LORD is. You watched Pharaoh bargain and harden his heart. Then came the Passover: a lamb without blemish, its blood on the doorposts, and the promise, "When I see the blood, I will pass over you." You walked through the Red Sea on dry ground and heard Moses say, "The LORD will fight for you." You sang the song of Moses and watched the song give way to grumbling at Marah. You prayed through three psalms of the exodus, and saw how the Psalms use the story as a resource for confession, for memory in distress, and for praise.

In the wilderness, God gave manna, water from the rock, and victory over Amalek. At Sinai, God described Israel as a kingdom of priests and a holy nation, and he gave the Ten Commandments, beginning with the words, "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out." On your second doctrinal day, you studied the three uses of the law and how the moral law relates to the Christian. You read the case laws of the Book of the Covenant and saw God's care for the sojourner, the widow, and the orphan. Finally, you watched the covenant sealed with blood, and the elders eat and drink in the presence of God.

The unit taught that God redeems before he commands, that the blood of the substitute is the ground of safety, and that the exodus is a pattern for all of God's saving work.

REFLECT

Review Questions

Why does it matter that God redeems Israel before giving them the law at Sinai?

Look back at Exodus 19:4 and 20:2. God reminded Israel of what he had done before he told them what to do. How does this order protect us from thinking that we earn salvation by obedience? Write a few sentences about how it changes the way you think about the commands of God in your own life.

What does the Passover reveal about the nature of atonement?

Think about the lamb without blemish, the blood on the doorposts, and the promise, "When I see the blood, I will pass over you." What does this teach about substitution and about how God's judgment and mercy meet? How does it help you understand the death of Jesus?

What are the three uses of the law, and can you find each one in Exodus?

Recall the civil, the pedagogical, and the normative uses. Where do you see the law restraining a violent people, exposing sin, and guiding the redeemed? Which use do you find most helpful for your own growth, and which do you tend to forget?

How does the Exodus function as a pattern for all of God's saving work?

Consider the slavery, the rescue by a mediator, the blood, the passage through water, the covenant, and the journey toward a promised land. Where do you see these themes fulfilled in Christ? Write a short prayer of thanks to Jesus for the greater exodus he has accomplished.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the exodus and for the greater exodus in Christ.

Ask him to teach you to obey out of gratitude.

Ask him to keep the unit verse near you.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 6 · DAYS 117-149

The Mosaic Covenant II: Tabernacle and Holiness

Exodus 25-40, Leviticus

God designs a way to dwell among his people. Holiness, sacrifice, and mediation.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For the life of the flesh is in the blood, and I have given it for you on the altar to make atonement for your souls."

LEVITICUS 17:11

Who may approach a holy God: Psalms 15, 24, 51, 50, 40, 91, and 92.

UNIT 6

In this unit

WEEK 17

117	Exodus 25:1-26:37	*Reading*
118	Exodus 27:1-28:43	*Reading*
119	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 18

120	Exodus 29:1-46	*Reading*
121	Exodus 30:1-31:18	*Reading*
122	Exodus 32:1-33:23	*Reading*
123	Exodus 34:1-35:35	*Reading*
124	Psalm 15	*Psalm*
125	Psalm 24	*Psalm*
126	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 19

127	Exodus 36:1-38:31	*Reading*
128	Exodus 39:1-40:38	*Reading*
129	Leviticus 1:1-3:17	*Reading*
130	Leviticus 4:1-5:19	*Reading*
131	Leviticus 6:1-7:38	*Reading*
132	Leviticus 8:1-10:20	*Reading*
133	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 20

134	Leviticus 11:1-13:59	*Reading*
135	Leviticus 14:1-15:33	*Reading*
136	Leviticus 16:1-34	*Reading*
137	Psalm 51	*Psalm*
138	Leviticus 17:1-19:37	*Reading*

139	Leviticus 20:1-22:33	*Reading*
140	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 21

141	Leviticus 23:1-24:23	*Reading*
142	Leviticus 25:1-26:46	*Reading*
143	Leviticus 27:1-34	*Reading*
144	Psalm 50	*Psalm*
145	Psalm 40:1-10	*Psalm*
146	Psalm 91	*Psalm*
147	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 22

148	Psalm 92	*Psalm*
149	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 117 · WEEK 17

Exodus 25:1-26:37

The Tabernacle design begins, ark, table, lampstand

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 25:1-26:37. These chapters are a set of building instructions, so read them slowly and let your imagination build the structure as you go. Notice that the first piece of furniture described is the ark, not the courtyard or the outer tent. God starts from the center and works outward.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses is on Mount Sinai with God, and the covenant has just been sealed (Exodus 24). Now God gives him a pattern for a tent that Israel is to build, so that the God who met them on the mountain can live in their midst. The tabernacle is a portable sanctuary, and it will travel with Israel through the wilderness. The instructions run from Exodus 25 to 31, and the building itself is told in Exodus 35 to 40. The whole project answers one question: how can a holy God live among a sinful people?

STEP 3

Observation

1. The offering for the tabernacle is voluntary, from “every man whose heart moves him” (25:2).
2. The purpose is stated: “And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst” (25:8).
3. Moses is told to make everything “according to the pattern” he was shown on the mountain (25:9, 40).
4. The ark of the covenant is a gold-covered chest with a lid called the mercy seat, and two cherubim face each other over it (25:10-22).
5. God says, “There I will meet with you” above the mercy seat (25:22).

6. The ark holds “the testimony,” the tablets of the law (25:16, 21).
7. The table of the bread of the Presence (25:23-30) and the lampstand shaped like a flowering almond tree (25:31-40) fill the holy place.
8. The tabernacle is made of curtains of blue, purple, and scarlet with cherubim woven into them, and a veil separates the Holy Place from the Most Holy Place (26:31-33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to notice is the purpose. God does not ask for a building because he needs a house. He asks for it because he wants to be near his people. “That I may dwell in their midst” is the whole point. The tabernacle is a statement that the God who thundered from the mountain intends to live in a tent among them.

The second thing to notice is the order. The ark comes first, and it holds the tablets of the law. Over it is the mercy seat, the lid, and between the cherubim God says he will speak. The law is under the throne, and mercy is on top of the law. When the high priest later sprinkles blood on the mercy seat on the Day of Atonement, the picture will be complete: the demands of the law are met by a sacrifice, and the way is open for God to meet with sinners.

The third thing is the language of Eden. The tabernacle is full of garden imagery. The lampstand is a tree with branches, buds, and almond blossoms. The cherubim recall the guardians placed at the east of Eden (Genesis 3:24). The fabric of the tabernacle has pictures of cherubim on it. The entrance to the sanctuary faces east, just like Eden. The tabernacle is a small Eden, a place where God and people may meet again. What was lost in Genesis 3 is being slowly restored.

The fourth thing is the layers of holiness. Gold, blue, and purple become richer the closer you get to the center. The veil marks a boundary that only one man can cross, once a year. The building teaches that God is near, and that his nearness is dangerous to sinners unless a way is made. The next few weeks of reading will explain what that way is.

Finally, notice the phrase “according to the pattern.” Moses is not free to design the tabernacle however he likes. This is the first clue that the earthly tabernacle is a copy of something heavenly, a point the letter to the Hebrews will make.

STEP 5

Connection

John says that the Word became flesh and “dwelt among us” (John 1:14). The Greek word means “tabernacled.” Jesus is the true dwelling place of God with man. Hebrews 8:5 says that the priests serve “a copy and shadow of the heavenly things,” quoting the instruction to make

everything according to the pattern. Revelation 21:3 promises, “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man.”

STEP 6

Application

Think about the first purpose of the tabernacle: God wanted to be near his people. Spend a few minutes thanking God that he wants to be with you, and not just to rule you.

Notice that the offering was voluntary and from the heart. Ask yourself whether your giving to God, of time and money, comes from a willing heart.

Remember that in Christ your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians 6:19). Ask God to help you live as someone in whom he dwells.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he chose to live among his people.
- Ask him to make you a willing giver.
- Thank him that in Christ he has come even closer.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 17

“And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst.”

EXODUS 25:8

DAY 118 · WEEK 17

Exodus 27:1-28:43

The altar, the court, the priestly garments

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 27:1-28:43. Yesterday took you inside the tent. Today takes you to the courtyard and to the clothes of the priests. As you read the description of the altar and the garments, ask what each one says about how a sinner can come near to God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The instructions for the tabernacle continue. Chapter 27 describes the bronze altar of burnt offering, which stands at the entrance, and the surrounding courtyard. Chapter 28 turns from the building to the people who will serve in it. Aaron and his sons are chosen as priests, and God gives detailed instructions for their garments. These are not ordinary clothes. They are "for glory and for beauty" (28:2), and each piece carries meaning.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The altar of burnt offering is made of acacia wood covered with bronze, with horns at its four corners (27:1-8).
2. The courtyard is enclosed by linen curtains, so that the people see the altar before they see the tent (27:9-19).
3. The lamp is to burn "from evening to morning before the LORD" as a perpetual statute (27:20-21).
4. Aaron and his sons are "brought near" from among the people of Israel to serve as priests (28:1).
5. The high priest wears an ephod with two onyx stones, each engraved with the names of six tribes (28:9-12).

6. The breastpiece has twelve stones with the names of the twelve tribes, and Aaron is to bear them "on his heart" when he enters the Holy Place (28:15-21, 29).
7. On the turban is a plate of pure gold engraved "Holy to the LORD" (28:36).
8. Aaron bears "any guilt from the holy things that the people of Israel consecrate" (28:38).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The order of the building teaches something. To approach the tabernacle, a worshiper had to pass through the gate and meet the bronze altar first. Before anyone could draw near to God, a sacrifice had to be made. The altar stood directly in the way. There was no path around it. The first lesson of the tabernacle is that sinners come to God by way of a substitute.

The second lesson is the role of the priest. Notice that Aaron is "brought near" (28:1), which means he was chosen, not self-appointed. No one can walk into God's presence on his own. A mediator is needed, and God provides one. Every piece of the priest's clothing speaks of his task. The ephod and breastpiece carry the names of the twelve tribes, on his shoulders and on his heart. He represents the people before God, with their weight on his shoulders and their names near his heart.

The gold plate on the turban says "Holy to the LORD." It is a remarkable detail. The priest is himself a sinner, and the people's offerings are imperfect. Yet verse 38 says that Aaron bears "any guilt" connected with their gifts. The plate on his forehead is a sign that even the best worship of sinners needs to be covered. This is humbling. Even our worship is not good enough without a mediator.

Finally, notice the "glory and beauty" of the clothing. The gold, blue, purple, and scarlet threads are the same colors as the tabernacle curtains. The priest is dressed like the building. This shows that the priest belongs to the sanctuary. It also shows that God's holiness is beautiful and not only fearsome. He is not a harsh master but a God of glory, and he wants his people to see it.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews tells you that Jesus is the great high priest who has passed through the heavens (Hebrews 4:14), who "always lives to make intercession" for us (Hebrews 7:25). Unlike Aaron, he has no sin of his own to cover (Hebrews 7:27). Peter says that all believers are now "a royal priesthood" (1 Peter 2:9). The altar finds its fulfillment at the cross, where Jesus offered himself once for all (Hebrews 10:10).

STEP 6

Application

Praise God for your mediator. Picture Jesus carrying your name on his shoulders and over his heart, as Aaron did for Israel.

If you tend to think that your prayers and worship need to be perfect before God will receive them, remember the gold plate. He receives them because of the priest, not because of you.

Ask God to help you serve others as a priest, by praying for them and bringing their needs before him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for carrying you on his shoulders and on his heart.
- Ask him to teach you to pray for others as he prays for you.
- Thank him that your worship is received because of him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 17

"And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst."

EXODUS 25:8

DAY 119 · WEEK 17

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Exodus 25:8 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst."

EXODUS 25:8

REST

Meditation

Exodus 25:8 is the heart of the tabernacle instructions. It is easy to lose it among the details of cubits and curtains, so give it a day to rest in your mind.

"Let them make me a sanctuary." The word "sanctuary" means a holy place, a place set apart. God is not asking for an ordinary building. He is asking for a place where the holy can meet the human.

"That I may dwell." This is the purpose clause. The God who made heaven and earth wants to live among his creatures. The verb is the root of the word "tabernacle" and of the Hebrew term shekinah, which later Jewish writers used for the presence of God. The whole Bible will keep returning to this theme: God wants to be with us.

"In their midst." The tabernacle was placed at the very center of the camp, with the tribes arranged around it on every side. God did not set himself apart on the edge. He lived in the middle of his people.

For the Christian, the verse points forward to Jesus, who “dwelt among us” (John 1:14), and to the church, which is “a holy temple in the Lord” and “a dwelling place for God by the Spirit” (Ephesians 2:21-22). It points forward as well to the day when “the dwelling place of God is with man” forever (Revelation 21:3).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you left the covenant at Sinai and began to read the instructions for the tabernacle. You saw the ark and the mercy seat, the table, the lampstand, and the curtains and veil of the tent. You saw the bronze altar and the courtyard, and you read about the garments of the priests, including the breastpiece with the names of the twelve tribes. The pattern is clear: God wants to dwell among his people, and he provides both a place and a mediator to make it possible. The week taught that approach to God is always by way of a sacrifice and a priest.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The tabernacle had a gate, an altar, a veil, and a priest between God and the people. What does this teach you about the way to approach a holy God?

How is Jesus the true tabernacle and the true high priest? What difference does it make that the veil is torn and you can come near through him?

Where in your daily life do you most need to remember that God is near and wants to be with you? Write a short prayer asking him to make his presence real to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for making his home with his people.

Rest in his nearness today.

Ask him to help you carry that nearness into the week.

DAY 120 · WEEK 18

Exodus 29:1-46

Ordination of the priests, mediation established

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 46 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 29:1-46. This chapter describes the ceremony that sets Aaron and his sons apart as priests. It involves blood, ashes, and many animals, so read it slowly and ask what it says about how a person is made fit to serve a holy God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 28 described the priests' clothing. Chapter 29 describes their ordination. It is a seven-day ceremony, and Leviticus 8 will tell how it was carried out. The rite involves washing, clothing, anointing, sacrifices, and the application of blood to the priests' bodies. The point is that no one, not even Aaron, can serve in God's presence simply because he wants to. He must be cleansed and consecrated by God's own provision.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The priests are washed with water at the entrance of the tent and then dressed in their garments (29:4-9).
2. Aaron and his sons lay their hands on the head of a bull, which is killed as a sin offering (29:10-14).
3. They lay their hands on a ram for a burnt offering, "a pleasing aroma, a food offering to the LORD" (29:15-18).
4. Blood from the second ram is put on the right ear, right thumb, and right big toe of Aaron and his sons (29:19-21).
5. The priests are sprinkled with anointing oil mixed with blood (29:21).

6. The ordination lasts for seven days, with a sin offering each day for atonement (29:35-37).
7. The daily offering of a lamb each morning and evening is described (29:38-42).
8. God promises, "I will dwell among the people of Israel and will be their God" (29:45).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The ordination ceremony shows that the priests' fitness for service is entirely a matter of God's provision. Aaron does not earn the right. First he is washed. Then he is clothed. Then he is anointed. Then sacrifices are offered on his behalf, and he places his hands on the animals to identify himself with them. The priest is cleansed before he is allowed to cleanse others.

The laying on of hands is worth noticing. It is a sign of identification. When Aaron places his hands on the bull, the animal stands in his place. It is not a magic act. It is a picture of substitution: the animal's life is given instead of the sinner's. This is the first time you see this in detail, and you will see it again in Leviticus.

The blood on the ear, thumb, and toe is a striking detail. The priest's hearing, his working hand, and his walking foot are all marked. It is a picture of a whole person given to God, set apart from head to toe for God's service. The priest hears God's word, does God's work, and walks in God's ways because blood has been applied to him.

The chapter ends with the promise that is the true goal of the whole system: "I will dwell among the people of Israel and will be their God. And they shall know that I am the LORD their God, who brought them out of the land of Egypt that I might dwell among them" (29:45-46). The exodus was for this. God did not just release Israel from slavery. He brought them out so that he could live with them. The sacrifices, the clothes, and the priests are the means. His presence is the end.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews contrasts the priests of the old covenant with Jesus. They were appointed "without an oath," and they were prevented by death from continuing, but Jesus is a priest forever (Hebrews 7:20-24). Peter says that believers are "a holy priesthood" (1 Peter 2:5), and the cleansing that makes this possible is Jesus' blood (Hebrews 9:13-14). John writes that Jesus "made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father" (Revelation 1:6).

STEP 6

Application

Remember that you do not serve God because you are fit. You serve because you have been washed and clothed. Take that as encouragement if you feel unworthy.

Notice the ear, hand, and foot. Ask God to set apart what you listen to, what you do, and where you go for his glory.

Pray for pastors and ministry leaders you know, that they would serve out of grace and not out of pride.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for washing you and making you fit to serve.
- Offer him your ears, hands, and feet, and tell him what you mean by it.
- Ask him to make your whole life an offering.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 18

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

DAY 121 · WEEK 18

Exodus 30:1-31:18

The altar of incense, anointing oil, bronze basin, the Sabbath

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 30:1-31:18. Today's reading finishes the instructions for the tabernacle with several smaller items and ends with a reminder about the Sabbath. Watch for the repeated theme of consecration, and notice how the Sabbath fits into the story.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

God has described the ark, the table, the lampstand, the tent, the altar, and the priests. Chapter 30 adds a few more items: the altar of incense, a half-shekel census tax for atonement, the bronze basin for washing, the anointing oil, and the incense. Chapter 31 names the craftsmen, Bezalel and Oholiab, who are filled with God's Spirit to do the work. It closes with the Sabbath command and with God giving Moses the two tablets. The next chapter will show how fast things can go wrong.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The altar of incense stands before the veil, and incense is burned on it every morning and evening (30:1-10).
2. Each person aged twenty and over pays a half shekel as a ransom for his life, "that there be no plague among them" (30:11-16). The rich do not pay more and the poor do not pay less.
3. Aaron and his sons must wash their hands and feet at the bronze basin "so that they may not die" (30:17-21).
4. The anointing oil is a special recipe, and it is not to be used for ordinary purposes (30:22-33).
5. The incense is "holy," and no one may make it for himself (30:34-38).

6. Bezalel is "filled with the Spirit of God, with ability and intelligence, with knowledge and all craftsmanship" (31:1-5).
7. The Sabbath is a sign between God and Israel "throughout your generations, that you may know that I, the LORD, sanctify you" (31:13).
8. "He gave to Moses, when he had finished speaking with him on Mount Sinai, the two tablets of the testimony, tablets of stone, written with the finger of God" (31:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Several themes run through these chapters. The first is atonement. The half-shekel ransom is the first time the word appears in the context of money. Everyone pays the same, because every life is equally in need of covering. No one can say that he is better than his neighbor, and no one can say that he is too poor to be included. The ransom is a quiet equalizer.

The second is the pattern of washing before service. The priests have to wash their hands and feet "so that they may not die." The language is stark. God's holiness is not something to take lightly. The bronze basin is placed between the altar and the tent, so a priest passes it on the way in. The point is cleanliness. A sinner does not approach a holy God casually.

The third is the Spirit-filled craftsman. It is a remarkable detail. Bezalel is the first person in the Bible described as filled with the Spirit of God, and the gift is for craftsmanship: woodworking, metalwork, and cutting stones. The Spirit is not only for prophets and priests. He equips people for skilled work in the service of God. If you have a skill, whether in teaching, building, cooking, or counting, it is a gift from the Spirit of God.

The fourth is the Sabbath. After all the instructions for building a sanctuary, God ends with the Sabbath. It is a deliberate order. The people are about to build a holy place, and God reminds them that holiness is also a matter of time. The Sabbath is a sign of the covenant, a reminder that Israel does not hold itself together by work. God is the one who sanctifies them. Even the project of building the tabernacle has to stop on the seventh day.

The final verse looks ahead. God writes on the tablets with his own finger. Moses will come down in the next chapter to a camp that has already broken the covenant.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that believers are not our own: we were "bought with a price" (1 Corinthians 6:20). Peter says it was "not with perishable things such as silver or gold" but with the precious blood of Christ (1 Peter 1:18-19). The Spirit who filled Bezalel fills every believer (Acts 2:4;

Ephesians 1:13), and Paul lists the gifts he gives for the common good (1 Corinthians 12:4-11). Hebrews 4:9-10 says that a Sabbath rest remains for the people of God.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God that the price of your redemption is the same for everyone, and that you cannot buy your way into his favor.

Think of the abilities God has given you. Ask the Spirit to help you use one of them this week in service to his people.

Treat the Sabbath as a gift. Ask yourself whether you are truly resting on the one day in seven set apart for it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are not your own.

Ask him to fill you with his Spirit and use your skills for his glory.

Ask him to teach you to rest in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 18

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

DAY 122 · WEEK 18

Exodus 32:1-33:23

The golden calf; Moses intercedes; God's glory and grace

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 32:1-33:23. This is one of the most dramatic passages in the Bible. The people break the covenant within weeks of making it, and Moses pleads for them on the mountain. Read it slowly and notice who speaks, who changes, and who is revealed.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses has been on the mountain for forty days, and the people below have grown restless. They believe he will not come back. While God is giving instructions for a house where he will live, Israel is building an idol at the foot of the mountain. The golden calf is the most serious sin of Israel in the wilderness, and its effects run through the rest of the Old Testament. It is also the occasion for one of the most powerful scenes of intercession in all of Scripture.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The people say, "Up, make us gods who shall go before us. As for this Moses, the man who brought us up out of the land of Egypt, we do not know what has become of him" (32:1).
2. Aaron collects gold, forms a calf, and declares a feast to the LORD (32:2-6). They say, "These are your gods, O Israel, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt" (32:4).
3. God tells Moses, "Your people, whom you brought up out of the land of Egypt, have corrupted themselves" (32:7).
4. Moses pleads with God, appealing to his reputation and to his promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Israel (32:11-13). "And the LORD relented from the disaster that he had spoken of bringing on his people" (32:14).

5. Moses breaks the tablets, grinds up the calf, and makes the people drink it (32:19-20).
6. The Levites rally to Moses, and about three thousand die (32:26-28).
7. Moses says, "Now, if you will forgive their sin, but if not, please blot me out of your book that you have written" (32:32).
8. God promises, "My presence will go with you, and I will give you rest" (33:14). Moses asks, "Please show me your glory" (33:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The golden calf is a lesson in how quickly people fall. Israel has just heard God speak, and they have promised, "All that the LORD has spoken we will do" (24:7). Within weeks, they are worshiping an idol. The sin is not that they stopped worshiping the LORD. They called the calf their deliverer from Egypt and held a feast "to the LORD." Their sin was to make God into what they wanted him to be, a visible and manageable image. The second commandment was broken before the ink was dry.

Notice what God says to Moses. "Your people, whom you brought up." God speaks as if Israel were no longer his. Moses answers by saying, "Your people, whom you have brought out." It is a quiet but important exchange. Moses will not let go of the relationship. He argues from God's own words and God's own name. It is a model of prayer: Moses holds God to his promises, and God relents.

Moses' offer in 32:32 is stunning. He asks to be blotted out of God's book if the people cannot be forgiven. He is willing to bear their punishment. God does not accept the offer. No ordinary man can pay for another man's sin. But the offer points ahead to someone who can.

Chapter 33 is the heart of the passage. God says that he will send an angel but will not go with them, because they are a "stiff-necked people." Moses will not move without the presence of God. "If your presence will not go with me, do not bring us up from here" (33:15). The whole point of the exodus was to bring God's presence among them. Without it, the land would mean nothing. God agrees. Then Moses asks for the most daring thing: "Please show me your glory." God answers by showing his goodness and proclaiming his name, and he covers Moses in the cleft of the rock, so that Moses sees only God's back. No sinner can see God's face and live.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that Christ has done what Moses offered but could not do: he became a curse for us (Galatians 3:13), and he was "made sin" on our behalf (2 Corinthians 5:21). Paul also wished himself accursed for his people (Romans 9:3), echoing Moses. Jesus, the "one mediator between God and men" (1 Timothy 2:5), intercedes for us (Hebrews 7:25). John says that no one has ever seen God, but the Son "has made him known" (John 1:18). Paul says that we see the glory of God "in the face of Jesus Christ" (2 Corinthians 4:6).

STEP 6

Application

Ask what idol you are tempted to build when God seems to be slow. Name it honestly in prayer.

Learn from Moses' example. Use God's own promises when you pray. Find one promise in this week's reading and pray it back to him.

Echo Moses' words: "If your presence will not go with me, do not bring us up from here." Ask God to make his presence the thing you want most.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess the idols you make when you are impatient.

Thank Jesus for doing what Moses could not.

Ask him to go with you, and to make his presence more precious than anything else.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 18

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

DAY 123 · WEEK 18

Exodus 34:1-35:35

Covenant renewed; the law rewritten; Moses' face shines

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 34:1-35:35. After the golden calf, the covenant is renewed. This is the other side of the story, and one of the most important statements of God's character in the Old Testament. Read the proclamation of his name in 34:6-7 slowly, and notice how often the rest of the Bible returns to it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses has interceded, and God has agreed to go with Israel. Now Moses is called back up the mountain with two new stone tablets. This time God does not simply give the commands. He proclaims his own name and character first. Then he renews the covenant, and Moses comes down with a face that shines. Chapter 35 begins the account of building the tabernacle, after the long set of instructions. The people respond with overflowing generosity.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God tells Moses to cut two tablets "like the first," and he will write on them himself (34:1).
2. "The LORD passed before him and proclaimed, The LORD, the LORD, a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness" (34:6).
3. God continues: "keeping steadfast love for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin, but who will by no means clear the guilty" (34:7).
4. Moses bows and worships at once, and asks God to go with them and pardon their iniquity (34:8-9).
5. God warns against making covenants with the people of the land and against idolatry (34:11-17).

6. Moses stays on the mountain forty days and nights, and writes "the words of the covenant, the Ten Commandments" (34:28).

7. Moses' face shines so brightly that the people are afraid, and he puts a veil over it when he is not speaking with God (34:29-35).

8. In chapter 35, the people bring gifts "every one whose heart stirred him, and everyone whose spirit moved him" (35:21), and the response is so great that Moses has to tell them to stop (36:5-7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Exodus 34:6-7 is the center of the passage and one of the most quoted verses in the Old Testament. It is the answer to Moses' prayer, "Show me your glory." God's glory, it turns out, is his character: mercy, grace, patience, love, and faithfulness. The list begins with mercy and ends with justice, and every word is deliberate. God forgives sin, and he does not ignore it.

The proclamation is repeated throughout the Bible. David uses it in Psalm 86:15 and 103:8. Joel quotes it in Joel 2:13, and Jonah complains about it: "I knew that you are a gracious God and merciful" (Jonah 4:2). It is a creed that Israel returned to again and again. When they sinned, they remembered who God is.

Look at what comes right after the proclamation. Moses bows down and prays. He does not argue. He worships and asks for pardon. The same man who was bold on behalf of the people is now humble in the presence of God's glory. The two postures belong together.

The renewed covenant shows grace at work. God could have ended things at the calf. Instead he cuts new tablets, with Moses doing the carving and God doing the writing. The broken covenant is mended, not because Israel has earned it, but because God is merciful.

The shining face is a sign that anyone who spends time in God's presence is changed. Moses does not know his face is shining (34:29). He has been with God, and it shows. The veil is for the sake of the people, who cannot bear to look. Paul will make much of this in 2 Corinthians 3.

Finally, the people's generosity in chapters 35 and 36 is the fitting response. They give so much that Moses has to tell them to stop. Forgiven people give freely.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul compares Moses' veiled face with the unveiled glory of Christ. "And we all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another" (2 Corinthians 3:18). John writes that the Word was "full of grace and truth" (John 1:14), using the words of Exodus 34:6. Jesus is the full revelation of God's glory (Hebrews 1:3), and the Father's steadfast love is shown in him.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Exodus 34:6-7, or at least the first half. Return to it when you doubt God's goodness.

Ask what it would mean for you to spend time with God so that others notice a change in you.

If God has forgiven you something, ask how you can respond with generosity this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God as merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in love.

Thank him for forgiving you in Christ.

Ask him to change you by your time with him and to make you generous.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 18

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

DAY 124 · WEEK 18

Psalm 15

Who may dwell on your holy hill?

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 15. It is short, with only five verses, and it asks a question that the tabernacle readings have raised again and again. Read it as a response to the instructions for the tent: who is fit to enter?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 15 is attributed to David. It begins with a question that fits the setting of worship at the sanctuary: "O LORD, who shall sojourn in your tent? Who shall dwell on your holy hill?" The "tent" and "holy hill" are the tabernacle and Jerusalem. After a week spent in the instructions for the tabernacle, this psalm answers from the point of view of a worshiper. It may have been used as an entrance liturgy, a set of questions asked at the gate by the priests.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The question: "O LORD, who shall sojourn in your tent? Who shall dwell on your holy hill?" (v. 1).
2. The answer begins: "He who walks blamelessly and does what is right and speaks truth in his heart" (v. 2).
3. The person "does not slander with his tongue and does no evil to his neighbor, nor takes up a reproach against his friend" (v. 3).
4. He despises "a vile person" and honors "those who fear the LORD" (v. 4).
5. He "swears to his own hurt and does not change" (v. 4).
6. He does not put out his money at interest or take a bribe against the innocent (v. 5).
7. The psalm ends with a promise: "He who does these things shall never be moved" (v. 5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm asks the question every worshiper of the tabernacle had to ask: who is allowed in? The answer is not about ritual. It is about character, and most of it is about how a person treats other people. Truthfulness, honesty in speech, faithfulness to promises, and fairness in money are the marks of someone who belongs in God's presence. The list is surprisingly practical. It is a picture of integrity in daily life.

Notice that the list begins and ends with a general statement: someone who "walks blamelessly" will "never be moved." The portrait is of a person whose inner life and outer life match. "Speaks truth in his heart" means that his words are the same as his thoughts. He does not say one thing and mean another.

It is wise to read this psalm with the laws of Leviticus in view. The sacrifices did not replace the call to live rightly. God never wanted offerings from people who ignored their neighbors. The prophets will say the same thing later. A sacrifice offered by someone who lies, slanders, and cheats is an insult.

But we must be honest. If we read this psalm as a checklist, we all fail. None of us walks blamelessly. Taken seriously, the psalm brings us to the same place as the tabernacle: we need someone to qualify us. The question is still open, and the next psalm will make it sharper.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the only one who truly walked blamelessly, and who spoke truth in his heart. He is the one who can dwell on God's holy hill, and he brings his people with him. Isaiah 33:14-16 asks a similar question and gives a similar answer. Paul says that we have been made "holy and blameless before him" in Christ (Ephesians 1:4). Hebrews 12:22 says that we have come to "Mount Zion and to the city of the living God."

STEP 6

Application

Read the list in verses 2 to 5 slowly. Pick one item where you feel convicted, and confess it.

Ask whether your speech is honest. Is there something you have said recently that was not quite true?

Thank God that in Christ you are welcome in his tent, not because you pass the list, but because Jesus did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask yourself honestly who may dwell on God's holy hill, and tell him what you find.

Thank Jesus for walking blamelessly and bringing you in.

Ask him to make you truthful, faithful, and fair.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 18

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

DAY 125 · WEEK 18

Psalm 24

Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD?

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 24. Yesterday's psalm asked who may stand in God's presence. Today's asks the same question again, and then celebrates the arrival of the King. Read the last section, verses 7 to 10, aloud as a procession.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 24 is a psalm of David and was probably sung when the ark was brought up to Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6). It has three parts: the earth belongs to the LORD (vv. 1-2), only the pure may come into his presence (vv. 3-6), and the gates must open for the King of glory (vv. 7-10). It joins together the tabernacle themes you have been reading about this week: God's holiness, the need for clean hands, and the ark of his presence.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The earth is the LORD's and the fullness thereof, the world and those who dwell in it" (v. 1).
2. He "has founded it upon the seas and established it upon the rivers" (v. 2).
3. "Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place?" (v. 3).
4. "He who has clean hands and a pure heart, who does not lift up his soul to what is false and does not swear deceitfully" (v. 4).
5. "He will receive blessing from the LORD and righteousness from the God of his salvation" (v. 5).
6. "Lift up your heads, O gates! And be lifted up, O ancient doors, that the King of glory may come in" (v. 7).

7. “Who is this King of glory? The LORD, strong and mighty, the LORD, mighty in battle!” (v. 8).

8. The question is asked again, and the answer changes: “The LORD of hosts, he is the King of glory!” (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a broad claim: everything belongs to God. He founded the earth. It is not a neutral world that we are free to use as we like. The earth is his. That is the basis for all that follows. The God who owns the world has the right to say who may come to his house.

Then comes the question of verse 3, the same as Psalm 15. The answer is about hands and heart: outward and inward cleanness. Notice that the one who ascends “will receive blessing from the LORD and righteousness from the God of his salvation.” Righteousness here is something received. It is not only earned. The one who is fit to stand in God’s presence has been given a righteousness he did not make.

The last section is a drama. The procession arrives at the gates of Jerusalem with the ark, and the gates are told to open. A voice from inside asks, “Who is this King of glory?” The answer comes: the LORD, strong and mighty in battle. The same exchange is repeated, and the title grows: “the LORD of hosts.” The ark is the sign of God’s presence, and the God who comes is a conquering King.

Look at how the psalm moves. It begins with the earth belonging to God, then asks who can come near to him, and ends with the King coming to us. The answer to the problem of who may ascend the hill is that the King descends. He comes to the gates, and he asks to be let in. It is a picture of the God who draws near to his people.

STEP 5

Connection

The early church read this psalm as a picture of Christ’s ascension. He is the one with clean hands and a pure heart, who ascended the holy hill and now sits at the right hand of the Father (Ephesians 4:8-10; Hebrews 4:14). Paul says that “the earth is the Lord’s, and everything in it” (1 Corinthians 10:26). Revelation 19:11-16 shows the King of glory returning as a conqueror. Jesus also stands at the door of the church and knocks (Revelation 3:20).

STEP 6

Application

Think of one thing in your life you tend to treat as belonging to you: money, time, or plans. Say aloud, “This is the LORD’s.”

Pray verse 7 as an invitation. Ask the King of glory to come in to a part of your life you have kept closed.

Thank Jesus that he ascended on your behalf, and that you can follow him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Welcome the King of glory into the rooms of your life that you tend to keep closed.
- Thank Jesus for ascending with clean hands and a pure heart.
- Praise him as the owner of everything.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 18

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

DAY 126 · WEEK 18

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 24:3-4 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

PSALM 24:3-4

REST

Meditation

Psalm 24:3-4 asks a question that the whole week has been asking, and gives an answer that should humble and then comfort you.

"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD?" The hill is Zion, the place of the sanctuary. To ascend is to approach God. It is the question of every religion: how can a person get close to the divine? The Bible's answer is honest. It is not for everyone.

"He who has clean hands and a pure heart." The answer has two parts, hands and heart. The hands stand for what we do, and the heart for what we are. God wants both. It is not enough to look clean. It is not enough to mean well. Both must be clean.

If you are honest, the verse is a problem. No one has clean hands and a pure heart. This is the very reason the tabernacle was built, with its altar, its priests, and its blood. A sinner cannot ascend on his own.

Then comes the gospel. Jesus is the one with clean hands and a pure heart. He ascended the hill. He did not do it for himself. He did it as your representative, and in him you are given "blessing from the LORD and righteousness from the God of his salvation" (Psalm 24:5). Because of Christ, you can draw near with confidence (Hebrews 10:19-22).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the instructions for the tabernacle and watched Israel break the covenant almost at once. You read about the altar and the priests' garments, the ordination of Aaron and his sons, and the extra items God commanded: the altar of incense, the basin, the oil, and the Spirit-filled craftsmen. You saw the golden calf, Moses' intercession, and his request to see God's glory. You heard God proclaim his name in Exodus 34:6-7 and saw the covenant renewed. You prayed through two psalms that ask who may enter God's presence, Psalm 15 and Psalm 24. The week taught that God desires to dwell with his people, that sinners need a mediator, and that his glory is his mercy.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

God described himself as "merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness." Which of these words do you most need to hear today, and why?

Moses offered to be blotted out for the sake of the people, but God did not accept it. How does Jesus fulfill what Moses could only wish? What does that mean for how you pray?

Psalms 15 and 24 describe someone fit to enter God's presence. Where do you fall short of the picture, and how does it change your heart to know that Christ has qualified you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are not left outside his tent.

Thank Jesus for bringing you in.

Rest in him today.

DAY 127 · WEEK 19

Exodus 36:1-38:31

The Tabernacle is built, every detail according to the pattern

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 84 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 36:1-38:31. After the long instructions, you now watch the work being done. Much of the text repeats what you read in chapters 25 to 31. As you read, notice what the repetition is meant to show.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The instructions are complete and the golden calf has been dealt with. Now the people build the tabernacle. Bezalel, Oholiab, and the skilled workers receive the offerings and do the work. The text slows down and tells again, almost word for word, what was commanded earlier, this time in the past tense. The point is not to tell you something new. It is to show you that the work was done exactly as God said.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The people bring so much that Moses has to restrain them: “The people bring much more than enough for doing the work” (36:5-6).
2. The craftsmen make the curtains, the frames, and the veil, using the same materials and dimensions as in chapters 25 and 26 (36:8-38).
3. Bezalel makes the ark, the table, the lampstand, the altar of incense, and the oil and incense (37:1-29).
4. The bronze basin is made from “the mirrors of the ministering women who ministered in the entrance of the tent of meeting” (38:8).
5. The bronze altar, the courtyard, and its pillars are made (38:1-20).
6. The total of the gold, silver, and bronze is carefully recorded (38:21-31).

7. The silver from the census, a half shekel per person, is used to make the bases for the frames and veil (38:25-28).

8. Bezalel does “all that the LORD commanded Moses” (38:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

It is easy to skim a chapter that repeats itself. Do not. The repetition is the message. When Exodus 36 to 38 says that the craftsmen made it “as the LORD had commanded Moses,” it is saying that Israel, who failed so badly at the golden calf, now obeys. The pattern of rebellion, intercession, forgiveness, and renewed obedience is one of the most important in the book.

The second thing to note is the generosity. The people bring so much that Moses has to stop them. This is the opposite of the golden calf. At the calf, they gave their gold to make an idol. Now they give their gold, silver, and bronze for the worship of the true God. The same people, the same metals, a different heart.

The third thing is the humble detail of the bronze basin. It is made from the mirrors of the women who served at the entrance of the tent. Someone gave up a prized personal possession so that the priests could be washed. It is not a large gift, and yet it is recorded forever. God notices what we give, and he does not forget.

The fourth is the use of the census silver. The ransom money, paid equally by each person, forms the foundation of the sanctuary. The bases that hold the whole tent up are made of redemption money. It is a quiet picture of the way God’s dwelling place stands on atonement. The whole structure rests on the fact that each person has been ransomed.

Finally, the long accounts of metal remind you that the tabernacle was real, tangible, and costly. It was not a spiritual idea. It was built with real labor and real gifts, by people who gave their time and skill.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul calls the church God’s building and says that “Jesus Christ himself being the cornerstone” holds it together (Ephesians 2:20-22). Peter says we are “living stones” being built into a spiritual house (1 Peter 2:5). The foundation is the ransom paid by Christ, “a lamb without blemish or spot” (1 Peter 1:19). Paul praises generous giving as “a fragrant offering” (Philippians 4:18).

STEP 6

Application

Think about the difference between the golden calf and the tabernacle. Ask whether anything you give, in time, money, or talent, is going toward something that cannot give life.

Give something this week, anonymously if you can, and without being asked.

Thank God that the foundation of your life with him is a ransom already paid.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the people who give cheerfully, and ask him to make you one.

Thank him for the ransom that is the foundation of his house.

Ask him to make you a living stone in what he is building.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 19

"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."

LEVITICUS 10:3

DAY 128 · WEEK 19

Exodus 39:1-40:38

Priestly garments made; the glory fills the Tabernacle

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 75 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 39:1-40:38. This reading ends the book of Exodus. The garments are completed, the tabernacle is set up, and the glory of God comes down. Read the last paragraph with particular attention, because it is the goal of the whole book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The priestly clothing is finished, and Moses inspects the work. A year after leaving Egypt, on the first day of the first month, the tabernacle is set up (40:17). Each piece is put in its place, and then something happens that no one could have arranged: God's glory fills the tent. This is the climax of Exodus. The book that began with Israel in slavery ends with God living among his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The priestly garments, ephod, breastpiece, robe, and turban, are made "as the LORD had commanded Moses" (39:1, 5, 7, 21, 26, 29, 31).
2. The plate of the holy crown is engraved "Holy to the LORD" (39:30-31).
3. Moses inspects the work: "Behold, they had done it; as the LORD had commanded, so had they done it. Then Moses blessed them" (39:43).
4. The tabernacle is erected on the first day of the first month, in the second year (40:2, 17).
5. Moses puts the testimony in the ark, sets the mercy seat on top, and brings the ark into the tent (40:20-21).

6. He anoints the tabernacle and the furniture, and washes and clothes Aaron and his sons (40:9-15, 30-32).
7. "So Moses finished the work" (40:33).
8. "Then the cloud covered the tent of meeting, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle. And Moses was not able to enter the tent of meeting because the cloud settled on it, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle" (40:34-35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The last chapter of Exodus echoes the first chapter of Genesis. In Genesis, God makes the world in six days and sees that it is good, and then he blesses it. In Exodus, Moses finishes the tabernacle, looks at the work, and blesses it. The words "So Moses finished the work" (40:33) are almost the same as "Thus the heavens and the earth were finished" (Genesis 2:1). The tabernacle is a new creation, a small world in which God and people may meet.

The date is also significant. The tabernacle is erected on the first day of the first month. It is a new beginning. Israel left Egypt in the month of Passover, and now a year later they have a new center to their life: a sanctuary for the God who brought them out.

Then the glory comes. The same cloud that led them through the wilderness settles on the tent, and God's presence fills the space so completely that even Moses cannot go in. It is a double lesson. God has come near. And he is still holy. Moses, the friend of God who spoke to him face to face, cannot enter. The nearness of God does not remove his majesty.

The book closes with a description of how the cloud guided Israel. When it lifted, they moved. When it rested, they camped (40:36-38). Their journey was ruled by the presence of God. They did not decide where to go. They followed him. This is the answer to Moses' prayer in chapter 33, "If your presence will not go with me, do not bring us up from here." It will go with them, day and night, "in the sight of all the house of Israel throughout all their journeys."

Exodus began with a groaning people and a hidden God, and it ends with a people who have seen his glory. The book is a short version of the whole Bible: redemption leads to God's presence. But the story is not finished, because Moses cannot enter. Leviticus will explain how others can.

STEP 5

Connection

John says that Jesus "dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory" (John 1:14). At the dedication of Solomon's temple, the glory fills the house in the same way (1 Kings 8:10-11). Paul says that believers are God's temple (1 Corinthians 3:16), and Revelation shows the glory of God filling the new Jerusalem so that it has no need of the sun (Revelation 21:23).

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on the end of Exodus. God rescued his people so that he could live with them. Thank him that this is the goal of your salvation, and not only forgiveness.

Ask yourself how much of your life is guided by his presence, and how much by your own plans.

Spend a few quiet minutes asking God to fill your life with his glory.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his glory fills his church.

Ask him to lead you day by day.

Ask him to let his presence rule your journey.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 19

"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."

LEVITICUS 10:3

DAY 129 · WEEK 19

Leviticus 1:1-3:17

Burnt, grain, and peace offerings, substitution and fellowship

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 1:1-3:17. A new book begins, and it starts with sacrifice. These chapters can feel strange and bloody, so read them as a guide to the way God teaches. Each offering has its own meaning, and you can learn to see it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Leviticus picks up exactly where Exodus ends. God speaks to Moses "from the tent of meeting," since Moses could not enter it in Exodus 40. The book is mostly a manual for priests and people on how to live near a holy God. It is the central book of the Pentateuch, and its theme is holiness. It begins with the sacrifices, because without a way to deal with sin, no one could survive in God's presence. Today's reading covers three of the five main offerings: the burnt offering, the grain offering, and the peace offering.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The burnt offering is a male without blemish. The worshiper lays his hand on its head, "and it shall be accepted for him to make atonement for him" (1:3-4).
2. The whole animal is burned on the altar, "a pleasing aroma to the LORD" (1:9).
3. The offering can be a bull, a sheep or goat, or a bird, depending on what the worshiper can afford (1:3, 10, 14).
4. The grain offering is of fine flour with oil and frankincense, and it is to be seasoned with salt but not leaven or honey (2:1-13).
5. Part of the grain offering is burned as a "memorial portion," and the rest is for the priests (2:2-3).

6. The peace offering is shared. Part is burned, part goes to the priest, and the worshiper eats the rest (3:1-17; see 7:11-18).

7. Throughout, the fat and the blood belong to the LORD: "It is a statute forever throughout your generations, in all your dwelling places, that you eat neither fat nor blood" (3:17).

8. The phrase "a pleasing aroma to the LORD" appears repeatedly (1:9, 13, 17; 2:2, 9; 3:5, 16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three offerings you read today teach three different things about the relationship between God and his people.

The burnt offering is about atonement and total dedication. The whole animal goes up in smoke. The worshiper lays his hand on its head, and the animal dies in his place. The word "atonement" means a covering or a ransom. The sinner has forfeited his life, and the animal's life is accepted instead. Because the whole animal is burned, it also pictures total surrender to God, a life given entirely to him.

The grain offering is a gift of thanks. It does not involve blood. It is an offering of the fruit of the worshiper's work, flour and oil, given back to the God who provided it. It is a reminder that atonement is not the only thing in the worship of Israel. There is also gratitude.

The peace offering is the happiest of the three, and it is about fellowship. The worshiper eats part of the sacrifice, in the presence of God, with the priest and often with family and friends. After atonement and thanks, here is a meal. It is a picture of what the whole system is for: peace between God and people, shared at a table.

Notice three details that run through the chapters. First, the offering is costly. Whatever you bring must be without blemish. Second, it is accessible. A poor person could bring a bird, a handful of flour, or a dove. No one was shut out for lack of means. Third, the blood and fat belong to God, because "the life of the flesh is in the blood" (17:11), a verse you will read soon and the anchor of this unit.

The repeated phrase "a pleasing aroma" is not about smell. It means that God accepts the offering. The sacrifice is not a bribe to a hungry god. It is a way for sinners to come to a holy God and be received.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that Christ "gave himself up for us, a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God" (Ephesians 5:2). He is the burnt offering, giving himself entirely. He is also our peace offering: he "is our peace" (Ephesians 2:14), and in the Lord's Supper we eat at his table. Paul says that Christians offer their bodies "as a living sacrifice" (Romans 12:1). Hebrews 13:15-16 speaks of a "sacrifice of praise" and sharing what we have.

STEP 6

Application

Spend a few minutes thanking God for the gift of Christ, the one who was the perfect, complete, and accepted offering.

Ask whether you have held anything back from God. Name it and offer it to him.

The next time you take part in the Lord's Supper, remember that it is a fellowship meal at the table of the one who made peace.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the perfect sacrifice in Jesus.
- Give thanks for the atonement, the gratitude, and the peace it brings.
- Offer him your life in your own words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 19

"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."

LEVITICUS 10:3

DAY 130 · WEEK 19

Leviticus 4:1-5:19

Sin and guilt offerings, the cost of atonement

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 4:1-5:19. Yesterday's offerings were voluntary gifts of worship. Today's are required, because they deal with sin. Notice who sins, how, and what each offering costs.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first three offerings in Leviticus were "sweet-smelling" ones, freely given in worship. Chapters 4 and 5 describe two offerings that are required when someone has sinned: the sin offering, or purification offering, and the guilt offering, or reparation offering. These deal with unintentional sin, wrongs done without the person realizing it at the time. They show that sin has consequences even when it is not deliberate, and they show that God provides a way for it to be cleansed.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The sin offering applies to anyone who sins "unintentionally" (4:2, 13, 22, 27).
2. The offering differs by rank: a bull for the anointed priest and for the whole congregation, a male goat for a leader, and a female goat or lamb for a common person (4:3, 14, 22-23, 27-28).
3. For the priest and congregation, blood is sprinkled before the veil and put on the horns of the altar of incense (4:6-7, 17-18).
4. The person lays a hand on the head of the animal and kills it (4:4, 24, 29).
5. "And the priest shall make atonement for him, and he shall be forgiven" (4:20, 26, 31, 35).

6. The remains of the bull for the priest or congregation are burned outside the camp (4:11-12, 21).
7. For those who cannot afford an animal, there are provisions for birds and even fine flour (5:7-13).
8. The guilt offering requires restitution plus a fifth of the value, along with a ram (5:14-6:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to notice is how seriously Leviticus takes sin. Even unintentional sin requires a sacrifice. This is surprising to modern readers. We often think that sin matters only when it is deliberate. Leviticus says that sin has an objective weight, and that it defiles. This is part of what it means that God is holy: he is so pure that even accidental contact with sin makes a person unclean. The text is teaching us that sin is not just about our intentions.

The second thing is the scale of the offerings. The cost rises with the person's position. A priest who sins brings a bull, just as the whole community does. Why? Because the sin of a leader affects everyone. The more influence a person has, the heavier the consequences of his sin. A common person brings a goat or lamb, and a poor person a bird. God's grace is flexible, but his standard of holiness is not.

The third is the blood on the altar of incense and before the veil. The blood goes closer to God's presence when the sin involves the priest or the whole people. It shows that sin does more than offend an individual. It pollutes the sanctuary itself. That is why the Day of Atonement, which you will read in a few days, includes cleansing the tabernacle.

The fourth is the repeated refrain: "and he shall be forgiven." It is the goal of the chapters. Sacrifice is not just a way of paying a price. It is a way of being forgiven. The sinner lays his hand on the animal's head, the animal dies in his place, the priest applies the blood, and the person is cleansed. The worshiper leaves forgiven.

The guilt offering adds a lesson. Sin against a neighbor requires more than a sacrifice. It requires restitution, repaying what was taken, with a fifth added. Forgiveness from God does not cancel the duty to make things right with people.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 13:11-12 says that the bodies of the animals for the sin offering were burned outside the camp, "so Jesus also suffered outside the gate in order to sanctify the people through his own blood." Paul says that God "made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we

might become the righteousness of God" (2 Corinthians 5:21). The word for "sin offering" in the Greek Old Testament is the same as the word for "sin" there. Isaiah 53:10 says the servant's life is made "an offering for guilt." Zacchaeus' restitution (Luke 19:8) shows the same principle.

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on whether you take unintentional sin seriously. Ask God to show you something you have not noticed.

Think of a wrong you have done to someone. Is there something you could do to make it right?

Thank God that the sin offering is finished in Christ, and that you can say "and he shall be forgiven" about yourself.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to forgive the sins you do not see.

Thank Jesus for being sacrificed outside the gate for you.

Ask him to show you what you need to make right.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 19

"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."

LEVITICUS 10:3

DAY 131 · WEEK 19

Leviticus 6:1-7:38

Priestly instructions for the offerings

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 6:1-7:38. These chapters repeat the offerings and add instructions for the priests. They can feel technical, so look for what they tell you about the priests' role and about the way worshipers were fed and cared for.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapters 1 to 5 were addressed mainly to the people, telling them what to bring. Chapters 6 and 7 are addressed to Aaron and his sons, telling the priests what to do with the offerings. They go over the burnt offering, the grain offering, the sin offering, the guilt offering, and the peace offering again, this time from the priest's perspective. They show what happens to the meat, who may eat it, and how to guard its holiness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The fire on the altar "shall not go out" (6:9, 12-13).
2. The priest wears linen garments to remove the ashes, and then changes clothes to carry them outside the camp (6:10-11).
3. The grain offering is eaten by the priests, "in a holy place" (6:16-18).
4. Anything that touches the sin offering becomes holy (6:27).
5. The guilt offering is "most holy," and the priest who offers it may eat it (7:1-7).
6. The priests receive a share of the offerings for their support (7:6-10, 31-36).
7. The peace offering must be eaten within one or two days, and anyone who eats it while unclean "shall be cut off from his people" (7:15-21).
8. The fat and blood are forbidden to eat (7:22-27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The detailed instructions reveal several truths. The first is the unbroken fire. The burnt offering fire on the altar must never go out. It was lit by God himself (Leviticus 9:24), and it was to be kept burning day and night. The priest's job each morning was to add wood and keep it alive. It is a picture of constant readiness. The way to God is always open, and the place of sacrifice never goes cold.

The second is the care for holiness. The priests change clothes. The ashes are carried to a clean place outside the camp. The utensils that touch the sin offering have to be cleaned or destroyed. The details teach that holy things are not to be treated casually. God's holiness is not passive. It sanctifies what touches it, and it is dangerous to what is unclean.

The third is the provision for the priests. They receive a share of the offerings as their food. God does not ask them to serve without support. This is an early example of the principle that "those who proclaim the gospel should get their living by the gospel" (1 Corinthians 9:14). It is also a reminder that the people's offerings feed those who serve them in worship.

The fourth is the careful rules for the peace offering. It must be eaten promptly and in a state of cleanness. A feast with God is not to be taken lightly. To come to the table when unclean is to risk being "cut off." This will be echoed in the New Testament, where Paul warns about taking the Lord's Supper "in an unworthy manner" (1 Corinthians 11:27).

Finally, the prohibition on eating blood is repeated, because blood is the life and belongs to God. This is the reason that blood is used for atonement. You will read the explanation in Leviticus 17:11.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the priest who offered himself, and he is also the sacrifice that feeds his people. "Whoever feeds on my flesh and drinks my blood has eternal life" (John 6:54). The fire that never goes out points to the Spirit who has been given to us (Acts 2:3). Paul says that Christians should "present your bodies as a living sacrifice" (Romans 12:1), and Peter says that we are priests who offer "spiritual sacrifices" (1 Peter 2:5).

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether the fire of worship is still burning in your life, or whether it has gone cold.

Think about how you support those who serve you spiritually, such as a pastor, a teacher, or a missionary. Is there a way you could support them more?

Next time you take communion, prepare yourself with care, and approach the table with reverence and gratitude.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep the fire of love for him burning in you.
- Thank him for feeding his people with himself.
- Ask him to teach you to approach his table with reverence.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 19

"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."

LEVITICUS 10:3

DAY 132 · WEEK 19

Leviticus 8:1-10:20

Priestly ordination; Nadab and Abihu, God's holiness is not safe

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 63 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 8:1-10:20. This reading includes the ordination of the priests, the first sacrifices, and a terrible event on the first day. Read the contrast between chapter 9 and chapter 10 carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The instructions in Leviticus 1 to 7 were given at Sinai. Now the narrative moves forward. In chapter 8, Moses carries out the ordination ceremony that was described in Exodus 29. In chapter 9, on the eighth day, the priests begin their ministry. In chapter 10, two of Aaron's sons make an offering that God did not command, and they die. The sequence shows both the glory of God's provision and the danger of approaching him on our own terms.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Moses washes Aaron and his sons, dresses them, anoints them, and offers the sin offering, the burnt offering, and the ordination offering (8:1-30).
2. The priests must stay at the entrance of the tent for seven days, "so that you may not die" (8:33-35).
3. On the eighth day, Aaron offers the sacrifices for himself and for the people (9:1-21).
4. Aaron blesses the people, and "the glory of the LORD appeared to all the people" (9:22-23).
5. "Fire came out from before the LORD and consumed the burnt offering and the fat on the altar, and when all the people saw it, they shouted and fell on their faces" (9:24).

6. Nadab and Abihu "offered unauthorized fire before the LORD, which he had not commanded them" (10:1).

7. "Fire came out from before the LORD and consumed them, and they died before the LORD" (10:2).

8. Moses says, "This is what the LORD has said: Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified" (10:3). "And Aaron held his peace."

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is one of the hardest passages in the Old Testament, so take it slowly. It shows two sides of God. In chapter 9, the glory of God appears and fire from heaven accepts the sacrifice. The people shout and fall on their faces. It is an overwhelming scene of acceptance. God has provided a way, the priests have done what he commanded, and he has come down to be with them.

In chapter 10, the same fire that consumed the sacrifice consumes two priests. The difference is that Nadab and Abihu offered "unauthorized fire." The text does not say exactly what was wrong with it. It says only that it was something God "had not commanded." The lesson is more important than the details. God is not to be approached in just any way we choose. He has told us how to worship, and worship that goes beyond his word is dangerous.

The event happens on the very day the priesthood begins. It is a warning at the start. The text is saying that God's holiness is not a matter of mood or ritual. It is who he is, and those who serve near him must take it seriously. Moses' explanation is the key: "Among those who are near me I will be sanctified." Those who are closest to God are held to the highest standard.

Aaron's silence in the face of the loss of his sons is a moment of great restraint. He does not argue, and he does not accuse God. He holds his peace. It is a hard, quiet response to a hard event.

We must also remember that the story is not meant to tell us that God is arbitrary. The sacrifices were provided for exactly this reason: so that sinners could approach safely. The danger was not in the system but in ignoring it. Those who came in the way God had commanded were welcome. Those who came another way were not.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 12:28-29 says, “Let us offer to God acceptable worship, with reverence and awe, for our God is a consuming fire.” Peter quotes the same theme, “Be holy, for I am holy” (1 Peter 1:16). The story of Ananias and Sapphira (Acts 5:1-11) echoes it, as the early church learned a similar lesson about deceit in worship. Jesus has made a new and living way open to us (Hebrews 10:19-20), and he is the way (John 14:6).

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself whether you come to God in the way he has taught, through Christ and in his Word, or in a way that suits you.

Take a few minutes to think about the seriousness of worship. Come to church this week with reverence.

If you are grieving a loss, ask God to give you the quiet courage that Aaron showed.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you think of when you hear that he is a consuming fire.
- Thank him for the new and living way in Jesus.
- Ask him to teach you to worship with reverence and awe.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 19

“Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified.”

LEVITICUS 10:3

DAY 133 · WEEK 19

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Leviticus 10:3 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."

LEVITICUS 10:3

REST

Meditation

Leviticus 10:3 is a sober verse to hold on a day of rest. It comes right after the deaths of Nadab and Abihu, and it is the explanation God gives for what happened. Do not rush past it.

"Among those who are near me." God speaks about his priests, and by extension all who draw near to him. Nearness is a privilege. It is also a responsibility. The closer you are to God, the more seriously he takes your obedience.

"I will be sanctified." To sanctify means to treat as holy. God will be treated as holy, either by willing worship or by his own action. It is not a request. It is a statement about how the world is. He will not be ignored.

"And before all the people I will be glorified." The worship of God is public. The conduct of those who lead worship is seen by everyone. His glory is at stake in how his people approach him.

For the Christian, the verse is a call to reverence. In Christ we are brought near, closer than Aaron ever was. We are not afraid, because the sacrifice has been made. But we are not casual either. Hebrews says, “let us draw near with a true heart in full assurance of faith” (Hebrews 10:22), and “let us offer to God acceptable worship, with reverence and awe” (Hebrews 12:28).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the end of Exodus and the beginning of Leviticus. You saw the tabernacle built exactly as God commanded and the glory of the LORD fill the tent. In Leviticus you studied the five main offerings: the burnt offering, the grain offering, the peace offering, the sin offering, and the guilt offering. You read the priests’ instructions for each, and you watched the ordination of Aaron and his sons. You saw the glory of God appear, and then you saw the death of Nadab and Abihu. The week taught that God makes a way for sinners to draw near, that he asks for obedience and reverence, and that the nearer we come, the more seriously he is to be honored.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The offerings in Leviticus 1 to 7 teach atonement, thanks, and fellowship. Which of these three do you most need to experience right now?

Jesus fulfills all of the offerings. How is he your burnt offering, your sin offering, and your peace offering? Write down one way each speaks to you.

God said, “Among those who are near me I will be sanctified.” What would it look like for you to approach God with both confidence and reverence this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to teach you to draw near with confidence and with reverence.

Thank him for opening the way through Jesus.

Rest in him, and ask him to be honored in your life.

DAY 134 · WEEK 20

Leviticus 11:1-13:59

Clean and unclean; skin diseases, holiness as separation

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 82 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 11:1-13:59. These chapters are some of the strangest in the Bible. They describe clean and unclean animals, childbirth, and skin diseases. Read them with one question in mind: what is God teaching his people about holiness?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the ordination of the priests and the offerings, Leviticus turns to the question of what is clean and unclean. The Hebrew words are tameh and tahor. “Unclean” does not mean “sinful” or “dirty.” It means unfit for the sanctuary. The laws apply to food, to childbirth, to skin diseases, and to mildew in clothing. They govern daily life, and they remind Israel at every meal and every household event that they are a people set apart.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The land animals that may be eaten are those that chew the cud and have a split hoof (11:1-8).
2. Water creatures with fins and scales are allowed, and other sea creatures are not (11:9-12).
3. Many birds and insects are named as unclean (11:13-23).
4. “For I am the LORD who brought you up out of the land of Egypt to be your God. You shall therefore be holy, for I am holy” (11:45).
5. After childbirth, a mother is unclean for a period, and then brings a burnt offering and a sin offering (12:1-8).
6. The priest examines skin conditions and declares a person clean or unclean (13:1-46).

7. The one who is unclean must "live alone. His dwelling shall be outside the camp" (13:46).

8. The same rules apply to mildew in clothing (13:47-59).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Why does God give these laws? The Bible does not give one simple answer, but the text points to several truths.

The first is explicit: the laws teach holiness. Leviticus 11:44-45 says, "For I am the LORD your God. Consecrate yourselves, and be holy, for I am holy." The food laws are one way that Israel's daily life is shaped by the idea of separation. At every meal, an Israelite was reminded that he belonged to a God who had set his people apart from the nations. These laws marked the boundary between Israel and the world.

The second is that they teach us to distinguish. The categories of clean and unclean train the people to think about the difference between what belongs in God's presence and what does not. Many of the unclean things are associated with death, decay, or disorder. The uncleanness of skin disease and discharge points to the brokenness of a world under death. These conditions were not sins, but they were signs of a fallen creation, and so they kept a person out of the sanctuary.

Third, the exclusion of the unclean person from the camp is a sobering picture. The person with a serious skin disease had to live alone, tear his clothes, and cry, "Unclean, unclean." It is one of the loneliest images in the Bible. It shows what sin and death do: they separate us from the community and from God's presence.

But note the role of the priest. He does not cause the uncleanness. He examines and pronounces. And as chapter 14 will show, the priest is also the one who declares a cleansed person clean. The system points to a need that it cannot meet. It shows that people cannot cleanse themselves.

We should be careful about using these laws for health advice, or for ranking people. They belong to Israel's life under the old covenant, and the New Testament tells us that their purpose has been fulfilled. In Mark 7:19, Jesus declares all foods clean. In Acts 10, Peter is told, "What God has made clean, do not call common."

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus touched lepers and healed them (Mark 1:40-42), and instead of being made unclean, he made them clean. Paul says that "nothing is unclean in itself" (Romans 14:14), and that in Christ the dividing wall between Jew and Gentile has been broken down (Ephesians 2:14). Hebrews 13:12 says that Jesus suffered outside the gate, in the place of the unclean. Peter's vision in Acts 10 shows the end of the food distinction as a mark of God's people.

STEP 6

Application

Think about the call to be holy and set apart. What areas of life show that you belong to God?

Remember someone who is isolated by illness, shame, or circumstance. Ask how you could reach out to them in the way that Jesus reached out to the lepers.

Thank God that in Christ, what was unclean is made clean, and that the barrier is gone.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to make you holy in a way that draws people to him.
- Thank Jesus for touching the unclean and making them clean.
- Ask him to show you someone who is alone and how you might reach them.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 20

"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy."

LEVITICUS 19:2

DAY 135 · WEEK 20

Leviticus 14:1-15:33

Cleansing rituals; bodily discharges, wholeness restored

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 14:1-15:33. Yesterday ended with the isolation of the unclean person. Today you read the ritual that welcomes a healed person back into the community. As you read, notice how much happens before the person is restored.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 13 described how the priest examines someone with a skin disease. Chapter 14 describes what happens when the person is healed. The priest goes out to the person, who is outside the camp, and examines him. If he is healed, a ritual with two birds and a series of offerings brings him back. Chapter 15 describes bodily discharges and the rules for cleansing. These chapters are about restoration. Where chapters 11 to 13 describe the problem, chapters 14 and 15 describe the way back.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The priest “shall go out of the camp” to examine the healed person (14:3).
2. Two live birds are taken. One is killed over fresh water, and the other, dipped in the blood, is released into the open field (14:4-7).
3. The person washes, shaves, and bathes, and then may enter the camp, but must stay outside his tent for seven days (14:8-9).
4. On the eighth day he brings a guilt offering, a sin offering, a burnt offering, and a grain offering (14:10-20).
5. Blood and oil are put on his right ear, right thumb, and right big toe, as with the priests (14:14, 17).

6. Provision is made for the poor, who may bring birds in place of lambs (14:21-32).
7. Chapter 15 describes unclean discharges, and what a person must do to be cleansed: wash, wait, and offer a sacrifice (15:1-30).
8. The purpose is stated: "Thus you shall keep the people of Israel separate from their uncleanness, so that they may not die in their uncleanness by defiling my tabernacle that is in their midst" (15:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The ritual for cleansing is more elaborate than you might expect, and it contains a beautiful picture. The healed person is outside the camp, and the priest comes to him. The priest does not wait at the sanctuary. He goes out to the one who is unclean. It is a small detail with a large meaning.

The two birds are a picture of death and release. One bird is killed, and the other is dipped in its blood and let go. The bird flies away alive and free, covered in the blood of the one that died. This is a picture of substitution and freedom. The death of one gives life to the other.

The anointing of the healed person's ear, thumb, and toe is the same as in the ordination of the priests (Exodus 29:20). He is restored not only to the community but to something like priestly dignity. A person who was cast out of the camp is brought into the tabernacle courts, marked with blood and oil. The healed leper is treated almost as if he were a priest.

The eight days also repeat the pattern of ordination. A person who has been cleansed is given a new beginning. And the provision for the poor shows again that the way back is open to everyone. No one is permanently excluded because he cannot afford the offering.

Chapter 15 on discharges might seem the most embarrassing material in the Bible, but notice its tone. It treats the body matter-of-factly. Uncleanness is not shameful. It is something that happens in a mortal body, and it has a procedure. The principle in verse 31 is the key. The danger is not the condition itself. It is defiling the tabernacle where God lives. These rules protect the nearness of God.

STEP 5

Connection

The Gospels record that Jesus healed lepers and then told them to go and show themselves to the priest (Luke 5:12-14; 17:14). They are fulfilling these chapters. Jesus went outside the camp to reach the unclean, just as the priest did. Hebrews 9:13-14 says, "If the blood of goats

and bulls... sanctify for the purification of the flesh, how much more will the blood of Christ... purify our conscience." Paul says that we are "washed" and "sanctified" in the name of the Lord Jesus (1 Corinthians 6:11).

STEP 6

Application

Think about the picture of the priest going out of the camp. Thank Jesus for coming to find you when you were far from God.

If you know someone who feels excluded, pray for a way to welcome them.

Recall the moment you were brought into God's family. Give thanks for the new beginning he gave you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for coming outside the camp to find you.
- Ask him to help you welcome others as he welcomed you.
- Tell him what it cost him to bring you home.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 20

"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy."

LEVITICUS 19:2

DAY 136 · WEEK 20

Leviticus 16:1-34

The Day of Atonement, the center of the entire system

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 34 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 16:1-34. This is the most important chapter in the book. Read it slowly, and picture the high priest going through the veil with blood. Then notice the two goats and what happens to each.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Day of Atonement, Yom Kippur, is the one day of the year when the high priest enters the Most Holy Place. The chapter begins with a reminder of the death of Nadab and Abihu (16:1), because the sanctuary is dangerous. Over the year, the tabernacle has been defiled by the sins of the people, and on this one day it is cleansed, and the sins of the nation are dealt with. It is the center of the whole system, and everything else in Leviticus is built around it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Aaron may not come “at any time into the Holy Place inside the veil” or he will die (16:2).
2. He bathes, puts on holy linen garments, and offers a bull for his own sin first (16:3-4, 11).
3. He takes a censer of burning coals and incense into the Most Holy Place, “so that the cloud of the incense may cover the mercy seat” (16:12-13).
4. He sprinkles the blood of the bull and the goat on the mercy seat and before it (16:14-15).
5. “Thus he shall make atonement for the Holy Place, because of the uncleannesses of the people of Israel and because of their transgressions, all their sins” (16:16).

6. Two goats are chosen. One is the LORD's, killed as a sin offering. The other is the scapegoat (16:7-10).

7. Aaron lays both hands on the live goat, confesses "all the iniquities of the people of Israel," and sends it into the wilderness (16:21-22).

8. "For on this day shall atonement be made for you to cleanse you. You shall be clean before the LORD from all your sins" (16:30). The day is to be a Sabbath of solemn rest, and a day of fasting, for all time (16:29-31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This chapter gathers up everything you have read in Leviticus so far. There are four parts, and each has a lesson.

First, there is the high priest's preparation. He cannot simply walk into God's presence. He must bathe, change his clothes, and offer a bull for his own sin. Even the mediator needs a mediator. The priest is a sinner, and his own sin has to be covered before he can cover anyone else's. There is a built-in sense that this system is incomplete.

Second, there is the entry into the Most Holy Place. Once a year, one man goes behind the veil, with a cloud of incense to shield him, and sprinkles blood on the mercy seat. This is the place where the tablets of the law lay, the testimony against Israel's sin. The blood goes between the law and the presence of God. The place that would condemn is covered by blood. This is atonement at its most vivid.

Third, there is the cleansing of the sanctuary. The tabernacle itself is purified because of the people's sin. Sin pollutes even the place where God lives, and it must be cleansed or God's presence cannot remain. This is an important idea. Sin has real effects on the world.

Fourth, there are the two goats. One dies, and its blood is used to cover sin. The other lives, and the sins of the people are placed on its head. It is sent away into the wilderness, to a remote and uninhabited place (16:22). Together, the two goats show two sides of atonement: sin is paid for, and sin is carried away. The people see their sin removed, and they know that it is gone.

Yet the sacrifice has to be repeated every year. Hebrews will say that this repetition is itself the proof that the blood of animals cannot finally take away sin. The Day of Atonement points beyond itself to a greater sacrifice, one that does not need to be offered again.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 9 and 10 interpret this chapter in detail. Christ entered "once for all into the holy places, not by means of the blood of goats and calves but by means of his own blood, thus securing an eternal redemption" (Hebrews 9:12). The veil was torn in two at his death (Matthew 27:51). He is the sacrifice and the high priest. Romans 3:25 says that God put him forward "as a propitiation by his blood." John the Baptist says, "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29), and Isaiah 53:6 says that "the LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all."

STEP 6

Application

Read Hebrews 9:11-14 and 10:19-22 today. Notice the contrast with Leviticus 16, and thank God for the finished work of Christ.

Picture the scapegoat going into the wilderness with your sins. Ask God to help you believe that they are truly gone.

Because the sacrifice is finished, you can come near with confidence. Spend a few minutes in unhurried prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for fulfilling the Day of Atonement once for all.
- Ask for a true heart and full assurance as you draw near.
- Tell God what it means to you that your sins have been carried away.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 20

"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy."

LEVITICUS 19:2

DAY 137 · WEEK 20

Psalm 51

True repentance, the heart beneath the sacrifice

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 19 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 51. After the Day of Atonement, this psalm shows the heart that stands behind the sacrifice. Read it as a prayer you could pray yourself, and notice how David asks for what the sacrifices could not give.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The title of the psalm says it is "A Psalm of David, when Nathan the prophet went to him, after he had gone in to Bathsheba." It is David's prayer after his sin with Bathsheba and his murder of Uriah (2 Samuel 11 and 12). It is the greatest of the penitential psalms. The situation is particularly striking against the background of Leviticus. David's sin was deliberate, and the sacrifices of Leviticus 4 covered only unintentional sin. He has no sacrifice to bring. All he can do is throw himself on God's mercy.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Have mercy on me, O God, according to your steadfast love; according to your abundant mercy blot out my transgressions" (v. 1).
2. "Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin!" (v. 2).
3. "Against you, you only, have I sinned and done what is evil in your sight" (v. 4).
4. "Behold, I was brought forth in iniquity, and in sin did my mother conceive me" (v. 5).
5. "Purge me with hyssop, and I shall be clean; wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow" (v. 7).
6. "Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me" (v. 10).
7. "Cast me not away from your presence, and take not your Holy Spirit from me" (v. 11).

8 “For you will not delight in sacrifice, or I would give it; you will not be pleased with a burnt offering. The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit; a broken and contrite heart, O God, you will not despise” (vv. 16-17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 51 is the honest prayer of someone who has sinned deeply and knows it. David uses the vocabulary of Leviticus: “wash,” “cleanse,” “purge with hyssop” (the plant used in the cleansing rituals of Leviticus 14). But he cannot use the sacrifices, because there was no sacrifice for what he did. He is thrown back entirely on God’s mercy. His first word is “mercy,” and the basis of his appeal is not his own repentance but God’s “steadfast love,” the same word you read in Exodus 34:6.

The famous line, “Against you, you only, have I sinned,” does not mean that David’s sin did not hurt Bathsheba or Uriah. It means that all sin is ultimately against God. The wrong to people is real, but the deepest wrong is to the one who made them in his image. A person who truly sees his sin sees that it is first of all an offense against God.

Notice that David says his problem goes deeper than his actions. “I was brought forth in iniquity.” He is not excusing himself. He is saying that sin is not just something he did. It is something he is. This is why he prays, “Create in me a clean heart.” He does not ask for help to do better. He asks for a new creation. The word “create” is the same one used in Genesis 1:1. Only God can make a clean heart, as only God can make the world.

The ending is the center of the psalm. “You will not delight in sacrifice… the sacrifices of God are a broken spirit.” David is not rejecting the sacrificial system. In verse 19 he looks forward to right sacrifices being offered again. He is saying that sacrifices without a broken heart are empty. The system always depended on the heart of the worshiper, and God has always looked for it.

Psalm 51 is not a way to get around the Day of Atonement. It is the prayer of the person who knows what it means.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told a parable of a tax collector who beat his chest and prayed, “God, be merciful to me, a sinner!” and went home justified (Luke 18:13-14). Paul quotes Psalm 51:4 in Romans 3:4. The “clean heart” and “right spirit” echo God’s promise in Ezekiel 36:25-27. John says, “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness” (1 John 1:9). In Christ, the broken heart finds the sacrifice it needs.

STEP 6

Application

Make this psalm your own prayer today. Read it aloud slowly, and let it lead you to confess whatever is on your heart.

If you carry guilt over something you have already confessed, remember the promise that God does not despise a broken and contrite heart.

Ask God to create in you the clean heart you cannot make yourself.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pray the words of Psalm 51 in your own words, telling God what you need cleansed.
- Ask him to create a clean heart in you.
- Thank him for Jesus, in whom your confession is answered.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 20

"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy."

LEVITICUS 19:2

DAY 138 · WEEK 20

Leviticus 17:1-19:37

Blood; sexual purity; love your neighbor

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 17:1-19:37. This reading includes the unit's anchor verse in chapter 17 and the well-known command to love your neighbor in chapter 19. Look for the connection between the sacrificial laws and the everyday ethical commands.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

With the Day of Atonement behind them, the book of Leviticus turns from how a holy God is approached to how a holy people live. Chapters 17 to 26 are often called the Holiness Code, because the refrain "You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy" (19:2) runs through them. Chapter 17 gives the reason for the prohibition on eating blood. Chapter 18 sets out sexual boundaries in contrast to Egypt and Canaan. Chapter 19 gathers a wide variety of commands for ordinary life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. All sacrifices must be brought to the tent of meeting, and not offered in the open field (17:1-9).
2. "For the life of the flesh is in the blood, and I have given it for you on the altar to make atonement for your souls, for it is the blood that makes atonement by the life" (17:11).
3. The prohibition of eating blood applies to sojourners too (17:10-14).
4. Israel is not to live as Egypt or Canaan do (18:3).
5. The laws of sexual conduct in chapter 18 are given because the nations around them "defiled" the land (18:24-30).
6. "You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy" (19:2).

7. The commands in chapter 19 include leaving the edges of the field for the poor (19:9-10), not stealing or lying (19:11), not withholding wages (19:13), and showing impartiality (19:15).

8. "You shall love your neighbor as yourself: I am the LORD" (19:18). "The stranger who sojourns with you shall be to you as the native among you, and you shall love him as yourself" (19:34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Leviticus 17:11 is the key to the whole sacrificial system, and it is the anchor verse of this unit. It tells you why blood is used. It is not because blood is magical. It is because "the life of the flesh is in the blood." Blood represents life, and life is given on the altar in the place of the sinner's life. "I have given it for you." The sacrifice is not a human invention to placate an angry God. It is something God himself provided. He gave the blood on the altar for your atonement. The system is a gift.

It also teaches that atonement is costly. A life is given. Sin is not forgiven cheaply. This is not a cruel principle. It reflects how seriously God takes sin, and how seriously he takes the value of life.

The chapters that follow show what holy people look like. Notice that the same chapter that commands "You shall be holy" also commands leaving the edge of your field for the poor and paying a worker his wages at the end of each day. Holiness is not only about worship. It is about how you treat your neighbor, your employee, the deaf person, the blind person, and the foreigner. "You shall not curse the deaf or put a stumbling block before the blind" (19:14) is one of the sharpest examples. The vulnerable are protected because God is watching, and "I am the LORD" is repeated like a signature on each command.

The great command in verse 18, "You shall love your neighbor as yourself," is in the middle of this chapter. It is not a new idea in the New Testament. It is the center of the law. The love is practical: it shows itself in honesty, fairness, and generosity. And verse 34 extends it to the foreigner, with a reminder: "for you were strangers in the land of Egypt." The memory of their own redemption is the basis for how they treat others.

The chapters also remind us that the call to holiness comes after atonement. The people can be holy because their sins have been covered. Grace comes first, and the life of holiness follows.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus calls the command to love your neighbor the second greatest in the law (Matthew 22:39), and he explains it in the parable of the Good Samaritan (Luke 10:25-37). Paul says that "the whole law is fulfilled in one word: You shall love your neighbor as yourself" (Galatians 5:14). Peter quotes Leviticus 19:2 in 1 Peter 1:15-16. And Hebrews 9:22 says, "Without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness of sins," based on Leviticus 17:11. Christ is the one whose blood was given for us.

STEP 6

Application

Read Leviticus 17:11 several times. Consider what it means that God gave the blood for you.

Choose one command from chapter 19 that speaks to your life. Where could you practice it this week?

Think of someone in your community who is a stranger or an outsider. How could you show love to them?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the life given for you.
- Ask him to make you holy as he is holy.
- Ask him to teach you to love your neighbor and the stranger.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 20

"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy."

LEVITICUS 19:2

DAY 139 · WEEK 20

Leviticus 20:1-22:33

Holiness for priests and people; sacred things

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 20:1-22:33. These chapters continue the Holiness Code with penalties for serious sin, and with strict rules for the priests. Watch for the repeated reasons God gives for his commands.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 20 lists punishments for the offenses named in chapters 18 and 19, including child sacrifice, occult practices, and various sexual sins. Chapters 21 and 22 return to the priests and the sacred offerings, setting a higher standard for those who serve at the altar. The reading is demanding, and some of it is hard to take in. It is important to remember that these were laws for Israel as a nation under the old covenant, in a time and a place very different from ours.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The laws of chapter 20 are tied to the command, “Consecrate yourselves, and be holy, for I am the LORD your God” (20:7-8).
2. God says, “You shall be holy to me, for I the LORD am holy and have separated you from the peoples, that you should be mine” (20:26).
3. The punishments are severe, including death for some offenses, because the land itself will “vomit you out” if it is defiled (20:22).
4. The priests must avoid contact with the dead, except for close family, and are to be careful about marriage (21:1-15).
5. A priest with a physical defect may eat the holy food, but may not approach the altar (21:16-23).

6. Unclean priests may not eat the holy things until they are cleansed (22:1-9).
7. Offerings must be without blemish (22:17-25).
8. "You shall not profane my holy name, that I may be sanctified among the people of Israel. I am the LORD who sanctifies you" (22:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The refrain of this section is the double statement of God's character and God's work: "I am the LORD who sanctifies you." In chapter 20, the people are told to consecrate themselves and be holy. In 20:8 God says he is the one who makes them holy. In 21:8 and 22:32 he says it again. The call to holiness is not a demand to make yourself holy by effort. It is a call to live in line with what God has already done by choosing and setting apart his people.

The severity of the penalties is meant to be understood in context. In a nation where God lived among the people in the tabernacle, serious sin was not just a private matter. It threatened the whole community, because it defiled the land and the sanctuary. The penalties show how serious these sins were in God's eyes. They also show that Israel, as a theocracy, had a unique role. We should not read these laws as a model for modern governments. The New Testament shows that the church does not carry the sword, and that discipline in the church takes the form of rebuke and exclusion (1 Corinthians 5).

The restrictions on the priests are another picture of the holiness of God. A priest must be physically whole and ritually clean. He serves a God of perfect holiness, and the priest's own body is meant to reflect it. These regulations may seem harsh, especially the rule about physical defects. But they were not a judgment of a person's worth. A priest with a defect still ate the holy food and shared in the priestly benefits. The point was to picture the perfection of the one who would come to be the true priest.

And note again that offerings had to be without blemish. God deserves the best. It is a theme that runs from Cain and Abel to Malachi, where God rebukes the people for bringing blind and lame animals (Malachi 1:8). What we give to God shows what we think of him.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the priest without defect, "holy, innocent, unstained, separated from sinners" (Hebrews 7:26), and the lamb "without blemish or spot" (1 Peter 1:19). Paul says that Christ "gave himself up for her, that he might sanctify her" (Ephesians 5:25-26), and that "God has called us not for impurity, but in holiness" (1 Thessalonians 4:7). Peter calls believers "a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation" (1 Peter 2:9).

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on the statement, “I am the LORD who sanctifies you.” Thank God that your holiness depends on his work.

Ask whether you are giving God your best, or what is left over.

Pray for the leaders of your church, that they would be examples of holiness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for setting you apart as his own.

Ask him to help you give him your best.

Thank him for Jesus, the perfect priest and spotless lamb.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 20

“You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy.”

LEVITICUS 19:2

DAY 140 · WEEK 20

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Leviticus 19:2 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy."

LEVITICUS 19:2

REST

Meditation

Leviticus 19:2 is the call that sums up the whole book. It is spoken to "all the congregation of the people of Israel," not just to the priests. Holiness is the vocation of every member of God's people.

"You shall be holy." The word means set apart, belonging to God. It has two sides. It means separation from what is sinful and common, and it means dedication to God. A holy person is not simply someone who avoids certain things. He is someone who belongs to God.

"For I the LORD your God am holy." This is the reason, and it is the whole reason. The command is not based on a rule but on a person. Israel is to be holy because their God is holy. The people of a holy God are to resemble him, as children resemble a father.

Notice the next verses in chapter 19. Holiness is not only about worship. It is about respect for parents, care for the poor, honesty in business, and love for your neighbor. To be holy is to reflect God's character in ordinary life.

For the Christian, Peter quotes the verse: “As he who called you is holy, you also be holy in all your conduct, since it is written, You shall be holy, for I am holy” (1 Peter 1:15-16). The call is the same, but the power is greater. In Christ you have been made holy, and the Holy Spirit lives in you to make you so.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you studied the heart of the book of Leviticus. You read about clean and unclean animals and the laws of skin disease, and you saw how the priest goes outside the camp to welcome a healed person back. You read the Day of Atonement, with the high priest entering the Most Holy Place and the two goats, one sacrificed and one sent away. You prayed Psalm 51, the prayer of a broken and contrite heart. You read the unit’s anchor verse, Leviticus 17:11, about the life in the blood. You read the Holiness Code, with the great command to love your neighbor as yourself, and the laws for priests and offerings. The week taught that atonement is costly and given by God, and that a forgiven people are called to be holy.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Day of Atonement showed sin being paid for and carried away. Which of these two pictures, the sacrificed goat or the scapegoat, speaks to you most today? Why?

Hebrews says that Jesus is both the high priest who enters the Most Holy Place and the sacrifice whose blood is offered. How does it change your sense of security to know that your priest and your sacrifice are the same person?

Leviticus 19 ties holiness to ordinary things like honest scales and care for the poor. Where in your daily life is God calling you to reflect his holiness more clearly?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that in Christ you have been set apart.

Ask him to help you love your neighbor as yourself this week.

Rest in his finished work today.

DAY 141 · WEEK 21

Leviticus 23:1-24:23

The feasts of the LORD; the lampstand and bread

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 23:1-24:23. Chapter 23 lays out the yearly calendar of Israel's festivals. Read it as a map of the year, and watch how often the word "rest" and the word "holy" appear.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The festivals of Israel mark the rhythm of the year around the agricultural seasons and, more importantly, around the great acts of God. They begin with the weekly Sabbath and run through Passover, Unleavened Bread, First Fruits, Weeks, Trumpets, the Day of Atonement, and Booths. Chapter 24 returns to the tabernacle with the lamp and the bread, and then describes an incident of blasphemy that leads to a ruling about justice. The chapters show that holiness extends to time as well as to space.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "These are the appointed feasts of the LORD, the holy convocations, which you shall proclaim at their appointed times" (23:2).
2. The weekly Sabbath comes first in the list (23:3).
3. The Passover is on the fourteenth day of the first month, followed by the seven days of Unleavened Bread (23:4-8).
4. The first sheaf of the harvest is waved before the LORD as First Fruits (23:9-14).
5. The Feast of Weeks comes fifty days after First Fruits, with a new grain offering (23:15-22).
6. The Feast of Trumpets and the Day of Atonement are in the seventh month (23:23-32).

7. The Feast of Booths lasts a week, and the people live in booths "that your generations may know that I made the people of Israel dwell in booths when I brought them out of the land of Egypt" (23:33-43).

8. A man who blasphemes the name is stoned, and the principle is stated: "You shall have the same rule for the sojourner and for the native" (24:10-23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The calendar in Leviticus 23 makes a point that is easy to miss: time itself belongs to God. Israel's year was not a series of random days. It was a story told in seasons. Passover recalled the night of the exodus. First Fruits recognized that the harvest belonged to the LORD. Weeks gave thanks for the grain. Trumpets and the Day of Atonement called the people to repentance. Booths celebrated God's provision in the wilderness. Every year, the people were reminded of who God is and what he has done.

The list begins with the Sabbath. Before the great festivals, there is the weekly rhythm of rest. The seventh day, each week, is a "holy convocation." It was the oldest feast, established at creation, and the foundation of the others. The point is that Israel's whole life is a pattern of work and rest, of effort and gratitude.

Notice how each festival is a response to something God did. They are not mainly about human achievement. Passover remembers rescue. Booths remembers the wilderness. First Fruits acknowledges that the harvest is a gift. The festivals teach the people to remember, and remembering is one of the main commands of the Old Testament. They are a form of teaching, put into the shape of a year.

The festivals also look forward. The harvest festivals point to a greater ingathering. The Day of Atonement points to a final cleansing. The feast of Booths, with its joy and its prospect of rest in the land, points to the day when God will live with his people forever.

The last part of chapter 24 includes the case of a man who cursed God's name. The point is that the name of the LORD is not to be treated lightly, and that the same law applies to everyone, native or sojourner. Justice does not play favorites.

STEP 5

Connection

The New Testament sees the festivals fulfilled in Christ. He is the Passover lamb (1 Corinthians 5:7). He is the "firstfruits" of those who have died (1 Corinthians 15:20). The Spirit came at Pentecost, the Feast of Weeks (Acts 2:1-4). Jesus stood in the temple at the Feast

of Booths and said, “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink” (John 7:37). Colossians 2:16-17 calls the festivals “a shadow of the things to come, but the substance belongs to Christ.” The church celebrates the Lord’s Day as a weekly remembrance of the resurrection.

STEP 6

Application

Think about your own calendar. Does it reflect what God has done, or does it only reflect your work?

Choose one rhythm this year, such as a weekly day of rest, or an annual time to remember God’s faithfulness, and plan for it.

Thank God for the way each of the festivals points to Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to teach you to number your days.
- Thank him for Jesus, the Passover lamb and the firstfruits.
- Ask him to let the rhythm of your life be shaped by his goodness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 21

“He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty.”

PSALM 91:1

DAY 142 · WEEK 21

Leviticus 25:1-26:46

Sabbath year, Jubilee, blessings and curses

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 101 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 25:1-26:46. The first chapter describes a Sabbath year and a Jubilee, which are among the most radical ideas in the law. The second sets out the blessings and curses of the covenant. Read them together and notice how the second grows out of the first.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel was about to enter a land that God was giving them. Leviticus 25 and 26 explain how they were to live in it. The land belongs to God, and the people are his tenants. Every seventh year, the land was to rest. Every fiftieth year, the Jubilee, property returned to its original family and slaves went free. Chapter 26 then sets out what will happen if Israel obeys and if it does not. It is the close of the Holiness Code and the covenant section of Leviticus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When you come into the land that I give you, the land shall keep a Sabbath to the LORD" (25:2).
2. In the seventh year, the land is not to be sown or harvested, and God promises to provide enough in the sixth year (25:3-22).
3. The Jubilee is announced on the Day of Atonement: "And you shall consecrate the fiftieth year, and proclaim liberty throughout the land to all its inhabitants" (25:9-10).
4. "The land shall not be sold in perpetuity, for the land is mine. For you are strangers and sojourners with me" (25:23).
5. A relative may "redeem" land or a person who has been sold because of poverty (25:25-28, 47-49).

6. Israelites are not to be treated as slaves, because "they are my servants, whom I brought out of the land of Egypt" (25:42).
7. Obedience will bring rain, harvest, peace, and God's presence: "I will walk among you and will be your God, and you shall be my people" (26:3-13).
8. Disobedience will lead to escalating discipline, ending in exile, and yet "I will remember my covenant with Jacob" (26:14-45).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Sabbath year and Jubilee are a vision of a society shaped by grace. The central claim is in 25:23: "The land is mine." Because God owns the land, no one can own it permanently. The Jubilee resets everything. Debts are cleared, land returns to the families who first received it, and slaves go free. It is a built-in safeguard against the growth of permanent poverty and inequality. No family could be locked out forever.

The reason behind this is the exodus. "They are my servants, whom I brought out of the land of Egypt." Because God redeemed Israel from slavery, Israelites are not to enslave each other. The memory of redemption shapes the economy.

The idea of a redeemer is also introduced here. A relative could buy back land or free a family member who had fallen into debt. This is the background for the story of Ruth and Boaz, and for the later use of the word redeemer for God himself. The redeemer is the one who pays the price to bring back what was lost.

Chapter 26 is the covenant's summary. It is a promise of blessing for faithfulness and a warning of discipline for rebellion. The blessing is rich: rain, harvest, safety, and God walking among them. But the curses are sobering: disease, defeat, famine, and finally exile. The warnings come in stages, with the repeated phrase "if you will not listen to me." God does not strike quickly. He disciplines and warns again, and gives space to turn.

The ending of chapter 26 is the most hopeful part. Even in exile, "I will remember my covenant." God says that he will not "break my covenant with them" (26:44). The covenant ends not with judgment but with a promise. This is the hope the prophets will cling to when the curses fall.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus began his ministry by reading from Isaiah 61, "to proclaim liberty to the captives… to proclaim the year of the LORD's favor" (Luke 4:18-19), which echoes the Jubilee. He is the true Redeemer, who bought us back from slavery to sin (Galatians 3:13; 1 Peter 1:18-19). Paul says

that the whole creation “will be set free from its bondage to corruption” (Romans 8:21). Hebrews 4:9 says that a Sabbath rest remains for the people of God.

STEP 6

Application

Consider the claim that everything you have belongs to God. Does that change how you hold your money, your home, or your plans?

Think about people who are trapped in debt or poverty. Is there a way you can act as a redeemer for someone in your life?

Rest in the promise that God remembers his covenant, even when you have failed.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you are holding too tightly, and ask him to teach you to hold it loosely.
- Thank him for the Jubilee Christ has brought.
- Thank him for remembering his covenant with you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 21

“He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty.”

PSALM 91:1

DAY 143 · WEEK 21

Leviticus 27:1-34

Vows and devoted things, the conclusion

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Reading · 34 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Leviticus 27:1-34. This is the last chapter of Leviticus, and it deals with vows and gifts to the sanctuary. It may seem like an odd ending, so read it as a final lesson about what it means to belong to God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the great statements of covenant blessing and curse in chapter 26, the book ends with an appendix about vows. A person might promise himself, his family members, his animals, his house, or his land to the LORD. This chapter explains how to value those promises and how to redeem them. It closes the book with a practical reminder that gifts to God are real, and should be taken seriously.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The chapter begins with “When a man makes a special vow to the LORD involving the valuation of persons” (27:2).
2. A person’s value is set in shekels according to age and sex (27:3-7).
3. The poor could be valued according to what they were able to pay (27:8).
4. A person who dedicates an animal cannot substitute a better or worse one (27:10).
5. Someone who wants to redeem a house or field must add a fifth to its value (27:13, 15, 19).
6. The firstborn of animals already belongs to the LORD and cannot be vowed (27:26).
7. “Every devoted thing is most holy to the LORD” (27:28).

8 “All the tithe of the land, whether of the seed of the land or of the fruit of the trees, is the LORD’s; it is holy to the LORD” (27:30). The book ends: “These are the commandments that the LORD commanded Moses for the people of Israel on Mount Sinai” (27:34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The last chapter of Leviticus may seem like an anticlimax, but it ties a few themes together.

The first is the seriousness of promises to God. A vow was voluntary, but once made, it was binding. The chapter provides a way to redeem what was promised, but at a cost. The lesson is that words matter. When you make a promise to God, it is not a casual matter. Ecclesiastes 5:4-5 will say the same: “It is better that you should not vow than that you should vow and not pay.”

The second is that everything belongs to God. The firstborn animals are the LORD’s already. The tithe is the LORD’s. The land is the LORD’s, as chapter 25 said. Even the idea of giving something to God is a recognition that he owns it all. When you give, you are not paying God. You are acknowledging what is already his.

The third is the matter of valuation. The chapter assigns a price to persons, and that sounds strange to modern ears. It is not a statement of a person’s worth. It is the amount required to redeem a person who was dedicated to the sanctuary. Without it, someone dedicated to the LORD would have no way back to normal life.

Look at the larger shape of the book. Leviticus begins with the call from the tent of meeting, and the first words are, “If anyone of you brings an offering to the LORD.” It ends with the tithe and the devoted things. The book began with the offering and ends with the offerer. It shows what a holy people look like: they have been redeemed, they have been cleansed, and they give themselves to God.

The final verse is a reminder of where all this began. These commandments came on Mount Sinai. The book is not a collection of legal puzzles. It is the voice of the God who rescued Israel, speaking to the people he lives among.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus praised the widow who gave two small coins, because she gave “all she had to live on” (Mark 12:41-44). Paul urges Christians to give “not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver” (2 Corinthians 9:7). Peter says that you were redeemed “not with perishable things such as silver or gold” but with the precious blood of Christ (1 Peter 1:18-19). The price that redeems you is not a figure on a chart. It is the life of the Son.

STEP 6

Application

Think about any promise you have made to God that you have not kept. Bring it to him honestly.

Ask whether you treat what you have as yours or as his. Choose one concrete act of giving this week.

Thank God that the cost of your redemption has been paid by Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give God what is already his, and tell him what you want to give.

Confess promises you have not kept.

Thank him for the price paid for you in Jesus' blood.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 21

"He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty."

PSALM 91:1

DAY 144 · WEEK 21

Psalm 50

I do not rebuke you for sacrifices, what God truly desires

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 50. After weeks of reading about sacrifices, this psalm puts a question to them. Read it as God's own voice, speaking in court, about what he truly wants from his people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 50 is a psalm of Asaph, one of the leaders of music in David's time. It is set in a courtroom. God summons the earth as a witness and speaks against his people. But the psalm does not say that the sacrifices were wrong. It says that Israel had begun to treat them as a way of handling God, as if he needed them. In the setting of the book of Leviticus, the psalm is a needed correction. It asks what the sacrifices were meant to do.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The Mighty One, God the LORD, speaks and summons the earth from the rising of the sun to its setting" (v. 1).
2. "Out of Zion, the perfection of beauty, God shines forth" (v. 2).
3. God says he will speak to his people: "Gather to me my faithful ones, who made a covenant with me by sacrifice!" (v. 5).
4. "I do not rebuke you for your sacrifices; your burnt offerings are continually before me" (v. 8).
5. "If I were hungry, I would not tell you, for the world and its fullness are mine" (v. 12).
6. "Offer to God a sacrifice of thanksgiving, and perform your vows to the Most High" (v. 14).

7. “Call upon me in the day of trouble; I will deliver you, and you shall glorify me” (v. 15).
8. To the wicked God says, “What right have you to recite my statutes or take my covenant on your lips?” (vv. 16-21). The psalm ends: “The one who offers thanksgiving as his sacrifice glorifies me” (v. 23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm does not criticize the sacrifices themselves. God says, “I do not rebuke you for your sacrifices.” What he corrects is a wrong idea about them. Some in Israel had come to think that the sacrifices fed God, or that they put him in their debt. God answers with a bit of humor: “If I were hungry, I would not tell you.” The cattle on a thousand hills are his. He does not need anything from us.

This is a necessary lesson for any religion. It is easy to think that our worship is a favor to God. The truth is the opposite. We need him, and he does not need us. Sacrifice does not make God our debtor. It is a way for us to receive from him.

What God wants, in place of a misunderstanding of sacrifice, is thanksgiving. “Offer to God a sacrifice of thanksgiving.” The word is todah, and it also names a kind of peace offering, the thanksgiving offering of Leviticus 7:12. God wants his people to come with gratitude, to keep their vows, and to call on him in trouble. The relationship is one of dependence and thanks.

The second half of the psalm turns to people who go through the motions but live wickedly. They recite God’s laws, but they steal, commit adultery, and slander. God’s response is sharp. He has been silent, and they have assumed that he was like them, but now he will confront them. The warning is that formal religion without a changed life is dangerous.

The last verse puts the two halves together: “The one who offers thanksgiving as his sacrifice glorifies me; to one who orders his way rightly I will show the salvation of God.” Thanksgiving and a right way of life belong together. This is the heart behind the sacrifice.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul told the Athenians that God is not “served by human hands, as though he needed anything” (Acts 17:25). Hebrews 13:15 says, “Through him then let us continually offer up a sacrifice of praise to God, that is, the fruit of lips that acknowledge his name.” Jesus said that the people honored him with their lips but their hearts were far away (Mark 7:6). Paul says that we are to “give thanks in all circumstances” (1 Thessalonians 5:18).

STEP 6

Application

Thank God today for five specific things, aloud. Treat it as an offering.

Ask whether your religion has become a way of handling God, rather than receiving from him.

Consider whether your life matches the words you say in worship.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he needs nothing from you yet receives your thanks.

Ask him to keep you from empty religion.

Ask him to let your life match your words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 21

"He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty."

PSALM 91:1

DAY 145 · WEEK 21

Psalm 40:1-10

I delight to do your will, obedience better than sacrifice

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 40:1-10. Yesterday's psalm said that God wants thanksgiving more than sacrifices. Today's goes further, with a line that the New Testament applies to Christ. Read verses 6 to 8 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 40 is a psalm of David. The first ten verses are a song of thanksgiving for being rescued, and the rest of the psalm is a prayer for help. In the first part, David describes how God brought him out of a pit and put a new song in his mouth. Then, in the middle of the thanksgiving, he says something that seems surprising in a week spent reading about sacrifices: God has not desired sacrifice and offering.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I waited patiently for the LORD; he inclined to me and heard my cry" (v. 1).
2. "He drew me up from the pit of destruction, out of the miry bog, and set my feet upon a rock, making my steps secure" (v. 2).
3. "He put a new song in my mouth, a song of praise to our God. Many will see and fear, and put their trust in the LORD" (v. 3).
4. "Blessed is the man who makes the LORD his trust" (v. 4).
5. "Sacrifice and offering you have not desired, but you have given me an open ear. Burnt offering and sin offering you have not required" (v. 6).
6. "Then I said, Behold, I have come; in the scroll of the book it is written of me" (v. 7).
7. "I delight to do your will, O my God; your law is within my heart" (v. 8).

8 “I have told the glad news of deliverance in the great congregation; behold, I have not restrained my lips, O LORD” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a rescue story. David was in a pit, a bog, and he could not get out. He waited, and God lifted him up and put him on solid ground. The result is a new song. A person who has been rescued cannot help singing. And the song is for others, too: “Many will see and fear, and put their trust in the LORD.”

In verses 6 to 8, David reflects on what God wants in return. His answer echoes Psalm 50, Psalm 51, and the prophets. It is not mainly sacrifice. What God wants is an open ear and a willing heart. “You have given me an open ear.” The Hebrew phrase is literally “ears you have dug for me,” the picture of a God who opens the ears of his servant so he can hear and obey. “I delight to do your will, O my God; your law is within my heart.” It sounds like the promise of the new covenant in Jeremiah 31:33, where the law is written on the heart.

David does not say that the sacrifices are worthless. He says that they are not what God ultimately desires. The sacrifices were always meant to be accompanied by obedience, and obedience is what they were pointing to. “In the scroll of the book it is written of me” may mean that David sees his own kingship described in the law (Deuteronomy 17:18-20). But the language is larger than David could fill. He is a king who delights in God’s will, but not perfectly. His words reach beyond him to the perfect obedient servant.

The psalm ends the section with public witness. David does not keep his rescue to himself. He tells the “glad news” in the great congregation. A rescued person speaks. He declares God’s faithfulness and steadfast love, and does not hide it.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 10:5-10 quotes Psalm 40:6-8 and puts the words on the lips of Christ as he comes into the world: “Sacrifices and offerings you have not desired, but a body have you prepared for me.” Jesus is the one who fully delights to do God’s will. He says, “I have come to do your will, O God.” And by that will, “we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all.” The sacrifices were always pointing to someone who would offer himself with a willing heart.

STEP 6

Application

Think back to a time when God lifted you out of a pit. Tell someone the story this week.

Ask the Lord for an open ear and a heart that delights in his will, not just one that obeys.

Read Hebrews 10:5-10 and thank Jesus for coming to do the Father's will on your behalf.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for drawing you out of the pit and setting your feet on a rock.

Ask him for an open ear and a heart that delights in his will.

Thank Jesus for coming to do the Father's will for you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 21

"He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty."

PSALM 91:1

DAY 146 · WEEK 21

Psalm 91

He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High, under God's wings

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 16 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 91. It is one of the best-loved psalms in the Bible, and it fits the end of a long study of the tabernacle. Read it as a description of what it means to live in God's presence.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 91 has no title in the Hebrew, and its author is not named. Jewish tradition connects it with Moses, because the previous psalm, Psalm 90, is "A Prayer of Moses." The psalm is a song of trust. It speaks first about dwelling in the shelter of the Most High, then switches to a promise spoken to the believer, and ends with the voice of God himself. After the reading of the tabernacle, with the glory-cloud, the wings of the cherubim on the ark, and the presence of God among his people, this psalm applies those images to the believer's life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty" (v. 1).
2. "I will say to the LORD, My refuge and my fortress, my God, in whom I trust" (v. 2).
3. "He will cover you with his pinions, and under his wings you will find refuge; his faithfulness is a shield and buckler" (v. 4).
4. The believer need not fear "the terror of the night," "the arrow that flies by day," "the pestilence," or "the destruction that wastes at noonday" (vv. 5-6).
5. "A thousand may fall at your side, ten thousand at your right hand, but it will not come near you" (v. 7).

6. “For he will command his angels concerning you to guard you in all your ways” (v. 11).
7. “Because he holds fast to me in love, I will deliver him; I will protect him, because he knows my name” (v. 14).
8. “With long life I will satisfy him and show him my salvation” (v. 16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The images of the psalm come from the tabernacle. “Shelter” and “shadow” recall the tent. “Under his wings” recalls the cherubim whose wings covered the mercy seat. The one who “dwells” in the shelter of the Most High is a person who lives in his presence. It is a picture of the believer as someone who has taken up residence in God’s house.

The promises that follow are bold. God will protect from plague, from enemies, and from danger. It is important to read them correctly. The Bible does not teach that believers will never suffer, and the psalm itself acknowledges that thousands may fall. The Bible also shows faithful people suffering, including Job, the prophets, and the apostles. The promise is not that nothing will touch you. It is that nothing will touch you apart from God. His presence is with you in the fire and the flood.

This is the lesson Satan missed when he quoted verses 11 and 12 to Jesus in the wilderness (Matthew 4:6). He took the promise of protection and tried to turn it into a license to test God. Jesus answered by quoting Deuteronomy: “You shall not put the LORD your God to the test.” The psalm is a promise to be trusted, not a tool for demanding proof.

The last three verses are spoken by God himself. “Because he holds fast to me in love, I will deliver him.” Notice the reason: not that the person is perfect, but that he holds fast. God’s love and the believer’s trust come together. “I will be with him in trouble; I will rescue him and honor him.” The deepest promise is the presence of God in trouble.

At the end, he says, “I will show him my salvation.” The word is yeshuah, the root of the name of Jesus. The psalm ends with the promise of salvation, which is finally a person.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus used the image of a hen gathering her chicks under her wings (Matthew 23:37). Paul says, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” and that nothing can separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus (Romans 8:31-39). Hebrews 1:14 says that angels are “ministering spirits sent out to serve for the sake of those who are to inherit salvation.” Jesus, the one who knew the Father’s name perfectly, is our refuge, and in him we dwell.

STEP 6

Application

Say aloud verses 1 and 2 as a personal declaration. Consider what it means to “dwell” in God’s shelter, not just visit it.

Think of a fear you have. Place it before the Lord and ask him to be your refuge in it.

Do not use this psalm to demand something from God. Use it to trust him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you want to hold on to him in.
- Thank him for his presence in every trouble.
- Ask him to show you his salvation in Jesus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 21

“He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty.”

PSALM 91:1

DAY 147 · WEEK 21

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 91:1 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty."

PSALM 91:1

REST

Meditation

Psalm 91:1 is the opening of a song of trust, and a fitting summary of the whole unit. After weeks of reading about the tabernacle, the sacrifices, and the priests, this verse takes the images and puts them into the life of a believer.

"He who dwells." The verb means to sit, to stay, to make a home. It is not a short visit. The Old Testament tabernacle was a place where God dwelt among his people, and now the believer is invited to dwell in God.

"In the shelter of the Most High." The word "shelter" means a hiding place or a covering. "Most High" is a title that speaks of God's supreme power over all things. The one who hides in him hides in the greatest of all places.

"Will abide in the shadow of the Almighty." A shadow is the place of protection from the heat of the sun. "Almighty" is the name Shaddai, the name by which God was known to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. The one who lives in God's shelter is under the care of the God who keeps his promises.

For the Christian, this verse is fulfilled in Jesus. We are "in Christ." We dwell in him, and he dwells in us (John 15:4-5). The shelter that the tabernacle pictured has been opened to all who believe.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the book of Leviticus. You read the calendar of Israel's festivals, and the Sabbath year and Jubilee with their promise of liberty. You saw the covenant's blessings and curses and the promise that God remembers his covenant even in exile. You read the last chapter on vows and the tithe. In the Psalms, you prayed Psalm 50, where God says he wants thanksgiving and not empty sacrifice, Psalm 40, where David speaks of an open ear and a heart that delights in God's will, and Psalm 91, a song of trust in the shelter of the Most High. The week taught that the festivals point to Christ, that God owns everything, and that the heart behind the sacrifice is what he wants.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Israel's calendar was filled with feasts that taught the people to remember what God had done. What practices help you remember God's work in your life?

Hebrews 10 places the words of Psalm 40:6-8 on the lips of Jesus. What does it mean to you that he delighted to do the Father's will on your behalf?

Psalm 91 describes a life lived in the shelter of the Most High. What is one fear you want to bring into that shelter today? Write a short prayer about it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is your shelter and shadow.

Thank him for the festivals and psalms that point to Christ.

Rest in him today.

DAY 148 · WEEK 22

Psalm 92

It is good to give thanks to the LORD, the Sabbath psalm

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Psalm · 15 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 92. It is the only psalm in the Psalter that is labeled "A Song for the Sabbath Day," and it ends this unit with praise. Read it slowly, and let it be a song of gratitude for everything you have read.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 92 is a song for the Sabbath. It was sung in the worship of Israel on the weekly day of rest. It is a psalm of thanksgiving that celebrates God's works and contrasts the end of the wicked with the flourishing of the righteous. It is a fitting close to a unit about God's dwelling with his people, because the picture at the end is of the righteous planted in the house of the LORD.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It is good to give thanks to the LORD, to sing praises to your name, O Most High" (v. 1).
2. The praise is "to declare your steadfast love in the morning, and your faithfulness by night" (v. 2).
3. "For you, O LORD, have made me glad by your work; at the works of your hands I sing for joy" (v. 4).
4. "How great are your works, O LORD! Your thoughts are very deep!" (v. 5).
5. "The stupid man cannot know; the fool cannot understand this: that though the wicked sprout like grass and all evildoers flourish, they are doomed to destruction forever" (vv. 6-7).
6. "But you, O LORD, are on high forever" (v. 8).

7. “The righteous flourish like the palm tree and grow like a cedar in Lebanon” (v. 12).
8. “They are planted in the house of the LORD; they flourish in the courts of our God. They still bear fruit in old age; they are ever full of sap and green, to declare that the LORD is upright” (vv. 13-15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a simple statement, “It is good to give thanks to the LORD.” Giving thanks is not a duty to be endured. It is good, a pleasure and a benefit. The psalm describes a day of rest filled with song and gratitude, with the harp and the lyre, morning and night.

The Sabbath is a day for remembering that God is the maker and doer. “You, O LORD, have made me glad by your work.” It is the work of God that makes the psalmist glad, not his own. The Sabbath is a day of rest because Israel’s life depends on what God has done. It is a weekly declaration that salvation is grace.

The middle of the psalm looks at the wicked. They may flourish for a time, “like grass,” but the grass withers. The psalmist wants us to see that apparent success is short-lived, and that God’s reign endures. “You, O LORD, are on high forever.” This is the steady center of the song.

The final image is one of the most beautiful in the Psalms. The righteous are like trees, a palm and a cedar, planted in the house of the LORD. A tree planted in a temple courtyard is sheltered, watered, and fed. And it keeps bearing fruit, even in old age. The picture is of a long, fruitful life lived near God.

This connects to the tabernacle. The tabernacle was filled with garden images, a lampstand shaped like a tree and curtains woven with fruit, because God’s dwelling place is the place where life flourishes. The psalm shows what happens to someone who is planted there. He grows. He does not dry up. And he lives to declare that the LORD is upright.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “The Sabbath was made for man” (Mark 2:27), and that he is “lord of the Sabbath.” He is also the vine in whom believers abide and bear much fruit (John 15:5). Psalm 1 describes the same flourishing tree. Paul says that believers are “filled with the fruit of righteousness that comes through Jesus Christ” (Philippians 1:11). Hebrews 4 promises a Sabbath rest for the people of God. And Revelation 22:2 describes the tree of life in the new Jerusalem, whose leaves are “for the healing of the nations.”

STEP 6

Application

Give thanks aloud for three works of God you have seen this week. Name them specifically.

Think about where you are planted. Are you connected to a local church, so that you can grow in the courts of the LORD?

Ask God to make you a person who keeps bearing fruit, even into old age.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give thanks to God for his work in you, in your own words.

Ask him to plant you in his house and keep you fruitful.

Tell him that he is upright and faithful.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 22

"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace."

NUMBERS 6:24-26

DAY 149 · WEEK 22

Review and Reflection

Unit 6 review, The Mosaic Covenant II, Tabernacle & Holiness

Year 1 · Unit 6 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For the life of the flesh is in the blood, and I have given it for you on the altar to make atonement for your souls, for it is the blood that makes atonement by the life."
>
> LEVITICUS 17:11

REST

Meditation

Leviticus 17:11 is the unit's anchor verse, and it is the clearest explanation in the Old Testament of why sacrifice works the way it does. Read it aloud once more before you continue.

"For the life of the flesh is in the blood." Blood is not a symbol of death only. It is the sign of life. When an animal's blood is shed, a life is given up. This is why the sacrifices were solemn. They were not a ritual meal but a taking of life.

"And I have given it for you on the altar." This is the surprise of the verse. The blood is something God has given. The sacrifice is not the people's attempt to reach God. It is God's gift to them. He gives the means by which they may be forgiven. The whole system rests on his initiative.

"To make atonement for your souls." Atonement is a covering or a ransom. The animal's life is accepted in place of the worshiper's. It is the substitute.

"For it is the blood that makes atonement by the life." The reason it works is that life is given for life. This verse answers the question of why anyone should approach God by blood. It is because the life of the substitute stands in the place of the sinner.

For the Christian, this verse finds its meaning in Jesus. He gave his life, and God gave him for us. "In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses" (Ephesians 1:7). "The blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin" (1 John 1:7).

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 6 you have read the second half of the book of Exodus and the whole of Leviticus. You began on Mount Sinai with God's instructions for the tabernacle. You saw the ark and the mercy seat, the table and the lampstand, the altar and the courtyard, and the clothing of the priests. You learned that the purpose of the whole project was stated in a single sentence: "Let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst."

You saw how quickly the people fell. While Moses was on the mountain, they made a golden calf, and he interceded for them. You heard him ask to see God's glory, and you heard God proclaim his name: merciful and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness. You watched the covenant renewed, the tabernacle built, and the glory of the LORD fill the tent. You prayed through Psalm 15 and Psalm 24, which ask who may stand in God's presence.

In Leviticus, you studied the five main offerings and what each one teaches about atonement, thanksgiving, and peace. You read how the priests were ordained, and how Nadab and Abihu died when they offered unauthorized fire. You studied the laws of clean and unclean, and you saw how the priest goes outside the camp to welcome the healed person back. The center of the unit was the Day of Atonement, with its blood on the mercy seat and its two goats, and you prayed Psalm 51 as the cry of a broken heart.

You read the Holiness Code and its great command to love your neighbor as yourself. You read the calendar of Israel's festivals, the Sabbath year, and the Jubilee, and the covenant's blessings and curses. You ended with the psalms: Psalm 50, which says that God wants thanksgiving more than empty sacrifice, Psalm 40, which speaks of an open ear and a delight in God's will, Psalm 91, a song of trust in God's shelter, and Psalm 92, a song for the Sabbath.

The unit taught that God is holy, that sin is costly, that atonement is God's gift, and that a forgiven people are called to be holy as he is holy.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What is the Tabernacle teaching us about how sinners can approach a holy God?

Think about the layout of the tent, from the gate to the Most Holy Place. Consider the altar, the basin, the veil, and the priest. Look back at Exodus 25:8 and Hebrews 9:11-12.

What does the sacrificial system reveal about the nature of atonement?

Review the five offerings in Leviticus 1 to 7. Look at the laying on of hands and the role of blood. Consider Leviticus 17:11 and what it means that God gave the blood.

What happens on the Day of Atonement, and how does it point to Christ?

Recall the high priest, the mercy seat, and the two goats from Leviticus 16. Read Hebrews 9:24-28 and 10:11-14. Ask what is different about Christ's sacrifice.

What does "be holy as I am holy" mean for the people of God?

Look back at Leviticus 19, where holiness includes love for neighbor, honest dealing, and care for the poor. Read 1 Peter 1:13-16. Ask how holiness is both a gift and a calling.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for teaching his people how to come near.

Thank him for Jesus, the blood on the altar for your atonement.

Ask him to keep the unit verse in front of you.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 7 · DAYS 150-199

Wilderness: Numbers and Deuteronomy

Numbers, Deuteronomy

Forty years of testing, failing, and being sustained. Moses prepares Israel for the land.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one. You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might."

DEUTERONOMY 6:4-5

Psalm 90 and Psalms 95, 96, 99, and 100 beside Numbers. Psalms 78 and 119 beside Deuteronomy.

UNIT 7

In this unit

WEEK 22

150	Numbers 1:1-2:34	*Reading*
151	Numbers 3:1-4:49	*Reading*
152	Numbers 5:1-6:27	*Reading*
153	Psalm 90	*Psalm*
154	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 23

155	Numbers 7:1-89	*Reading*
156	Numbers 8:1-10:36	*Reading*
157	Numbers 11:1-12:16	*Reading*
158	Numbers 13:1-14:45	*Reading*
159	Psalm 95	*Psalm*
160	Psalm 96	*Psalm*
161	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 24

162	Numbers 15:1-16:50	*Reading*
163	Numbers 17:1-19:22	*Reading*
164	Numbers 20:1-21:35	*Reading*
165	Numbers 22:1-24:25	*Reading*
166	Psalm 99	*Psalm*
167	Psalm 100	*Psalm*
168	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 25

169	Numbers 25:1-27:23	*Reading*
170	Numbers 28:1-30:16	*Reading*
171	Numbers 31:1-32:42	*Reading*

172	Numbers 33:1-34:29	*Reading*
173	Numbers 35:1-36:13	*Reading*
174	Deuteronomy 1:1-3:29	*Reading*
175	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 26

176	Psalm 78:1-39	*Psalm*
177	Deuteronomy 4:1-5:33	*Reading*
178	Deuteronomy 6:1-8:20	*Reading*
179	Deuteronomy 9:1-11:32	*Reading*
180	Psalm 78:40-72	*Psalm*
181	Deuteronomy 12:1-14:29	*Reading*
182	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 27

183	Deuteronomy 15:1-16:22	*Reading*
184	Deuteronomy 18:15-19; Psalm 110; Hebrews 1:1-4	*Doctrine*
185	Deuteronomy 17:1-18:22	*Reading*
186	Deuteronomy 19:1-21:23	*Reading*
187	Deuteronomy 22:1-25:19	*Reading*
188	Deuteronomy 26:1-28:14	*Reading*
189	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 28

190	Psalm 119:1-48	*Psalm*
191	Psalm 119:49-96	*Psalm*
192	Deuteronomy 28:15-68	*Reading*
193	Deuteronomy 29:1-31:29	*Reading*
194	Deuteronomy 31:30-32:52	*Reading*
195	Deuteronomy 33:1-34:12	*Reading*
196	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 29

197	Psalm 119:97-144	*Psalm*
198	Psalm 119:145-176	*Psalm*
199	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 150 · WEEK 22

Numbers 1:1-2:34

The census, God's ordered people prepared for the journey

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 89 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 1:1-2:34. A new book begins, and it opens with a census and a camp plan. The text is full of numbers, so read it for the pattern and not for the arithmetic. Ask what it says about how God organizes and cares for his people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has been at Mount Sinai for almost a year. The covenant has been made, the tabernacle built, and the laws of Leviticus given. Now, on the first day of the second month of the second year, God tells Moses to count the fighting men and to arrange the camp. Numbers takes its English name from these censuses, though the Hebrew title is "In the wilderness." The book tells how a redeemed people travel from Sinai toward the land God promised, and how a whole generation fails to enter it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God commands Moses to number "all the congregation of the people of Israel, by clans, by fathers" houses' (1:2).
2. Each tribe has a named leader who helps with the count (1:5-16).
3. The total of men twenty years old and up, able to go to war, is 603,550 (1:46).
4. The Levites are not counted with the rest, because they are to care for the tabernacle (1:47-53).
5. The tribes camp around the tabernacle, three on each side, "each by his own banner" (2:2).
6. Judah camps on the east, the side of the entrance, and leads out first (2:3, 9).

7. The tabernacle and the Levites are at the center of the camp (2:17).
8. “Thus did the people of Israel. According to all that the LORD commanded Moses, so they camped by their standards, and so they set out” (2:34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

A census may seem a dull way to begin a book, but it says something important. God knows his people by name and by family. Each tribe has a leader. Each man is counted. In a world where slaves were nameless, Israel is a people whose members are known. The counting recalls the promise to Abraham of descendants like the stars, now visibly coming true in a host of hundreds of thousands.

The census is also a military preparation. Israel is about to march toward a land that other nations hold. The numbers are meant to give confidence, and they also bring responsibility, since each man counted is accountable to serve. But this army is not led by generals. It follows the tabernacle, and the cloud.

The camp plan is a picture in space. The tabernacle sits in the center, and twelve tribes surround it in four groups of three. God does not dwell at the edge. He is the center, and all of life is arranged around him. The Levites camp between the tabernacle and the people, a protective ring that reflects the holiness you read about in Leviticus. Everyone has a place, and no one is left out.

Notice the repeated phrase, “as the LORD commanded Moses.” The book begins with obedience. It is the high point before the failure that follows. For a moment, Israel is exactly what God designed: a people in order, near their God, ready to move. The tragedy of the rest of Numbers is that this orderly people will not trust the God who has arranged them.

For us, the lesson is simple. God does not scatter his people. He gathers them around himself and gives each a place and a task.

STEP 5

Connection

The church is described in the same terms. Paul says that God arranged the members of the body “as he chose” (1 Corinthians 12:18), and Ephesians 4:16 speaks of the whole body “joined and held together.” Hebrews 12:23 speaks of “the assembly of the firstborn who are enrolled in heaven,” and Jesus told his disciples to rejoice that their names are written in heaven (Luke 10:20). Revelation 21:12-14 pictures the twelve tribes and the twelve apostles around the new Jerusalem.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God that he knows you by name, and that you are counted among his people.

Ask where your place is in the body of Christ, and whether you are filling it.

Notice the centrality of the tabernacle in Israel's camp, and ask what is at the center of your life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he knows his people by name and that you are counted among them.

Ask him to put you where he wants you in his body.

Ask him to keep himself at the center of your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 22

"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace."

NUMBERS 6:24-26

DAY 151 · WEEK 22

Numbers 3:1-4:49

The Levites and their duties, sacred service

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 97 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 3:1-4:49. Yesterday you saw the camp of the tribes. Today you read about the tribe of Levi, who were set apart to serve in the tabernacle. Notice the contrast between the Levites and the firstborn of Israel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Numbers 3 and 4 describe the Levites, the tribe of Moses and Aaron. They are not counted with the army, because their work is different: they guard and carry the tabernacle. The chapters list the three clans of Levi, Gershon, Kohath, and Merari, and assign each a duty. They also explain why the Levites belong to God. When the firstborn of Egypt died at the Passover, the firstborn of Israel were spared, and so they belonged to the LORD. God takes the Levites as a substitute for them.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The sons of Aaron are named, and the death of Nadab and Abihu is recalled (3:1-4).
2. The Levites are given to Aaron “as a gift” to assist him (3:5-10).
3. “I have taken the Levites from among the people of Israel instead of every firstborn” (3:12).
4. The three clans of Levi camp on three sides of the tabernacle, with Moses and Aaron at the east (3:21-39).
5. The firstborn of Israel outnumber the Levites by 273, and each of the extra is redeemed for five shekels (3:40-51).

6. The Kohathites carry the holy things, but must not touch or look at them, “lest they die” (4:15, 20).
7. Aaron and his sons must first cover the furniture before the Kohathites come to carry it (4:5-15).
8. The Levites serve from age thirty to fifty (4:3, 23, 30).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This section teaches one of the Bible’s basic ideas: substitution. The firstborn of Israel were saved at the Passover, and they belonged to God because of it. Instead of requiring every firstborn son to serve at the sanctuary, God takes the Levites in their place. The Levites stand in for the firstborn, and when there are extra firstborn, a ransom price is paid. The principle is that a life spared must be given back to the one who spared it.

The Levites’ work is a lesson in reverence. The Kohathites carry the most holy things, but they are never allowed to touch them or look at them directly. The priests have to cover the furniture first. It is a vivid warning that God’s holiness is not casual. Even people set apart to serve him can only approach him in the way he has provided.

The text also shows the dignity of ordinary service. Much of the Levites’ work was carrying poles and curtains. It was heavy and repetitive. But Numbers describes it carefully, with each task named, because in God’s household no task is small. The people who carried the tent poles are as precisely recorded as the priests who burned the incense.

And the redemption of the extra firstborn shows how seriously God takes the ransom principle. Five shekels each is a price, a reminder that the people did not belong to themselves.

All of this prepares the reader for the greater substitution. God spared Israel’s firstborn, and then God gave his own firstborn, the only Son, as a ransom for many.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is called “the firstborn of all creation” and “the firstborn from the dead” (Colossians 1:15, 18). Believers are called “the assembly of the firstborn” (Hebrews 12:23). Peter says that you were “ransomed from the futile ways inherited from your forefathers, not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but with the precious blood of Christ” (1 Peter 1:18-19). Paul says that you are not your own, because you were bought with a price (1 Corinthians 6:19-20).

STEP 6

Application

Think about what it means to belong to God because of what he has done for you. Ask how that shapes your daily choices.

Honor those who do humble service in your church, such as people who set up, clean, or carry.

Receive the ransom with gratitude, and offer your service back to the one who redeemed you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the ransom of his Son, and tell him what it means that you are not your own.

Offer him your hands and your days, naming one thing specific.

Ask him to teach you to honor his holiness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 22

"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace."

NUMBERS 6:24-26

DAY 152 · WEEK 22

Numbers 5:1-6:27

Purity laws; the Nazirite vow; the Aaronic blessing

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 5:1-6:27. This reading includes some unusual laws about purity and suspicion, the Nazirite vow, and the best-known blessing in the Old Testament. Read the blessing at the end aloud.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The camp is arranged, and now it has to be kept clean, because God lives in it. Chapter 5 deals with people who are unclean, with wrongs that need restitution, and with a ritual for a suspected case of unfaithfulness in marriage. Chapter 6 describes the Nazirite vow, a special period of consecration that anyone could take. The chapter ends with the words Aaron and his sons were to speak over Israel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. People with skin diseases or discharges, or who have touched the dead, are sent out of the camp, “that they may not defile their camp, in the midst of which I dwell” (5:1-4).
2. A person who wrongs another must confess, make restitution, and add a fifth (5:5-10).
3. The ritual for a suspected wife is described in detail (5:11-31).
4. A Nazirite vows to abstain from wine and grape products, to let the hair grow, and to avoid contact with the dead (6:1-8).
5. If the vow is broken by accident, the Nazirite shaves and brings offerings (6:9-12).
6. At the end of the vow, offerings are made, and the hair is burned (6:13-21).
7. “The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace” (6:24-

26).

8 “So shall they put my name upon the people of Israel, and I will bless them” (6:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The laws in chapter 5 continue the theme of God’s presence in the camp. Since the LORD dwells among them, anything that spoils the community’s purity is a serious matter. It is not just about private cleanliness. The people are one body, and the sin or uncleanness of one affects all.

The law about restitution is worth noting. Confession is not enough. A person who has wronged someone must pay back what was taken, plus a fifth, and the payment goes to the wronged person. True repentance has practical shape.

The suspected-adultery ritual is unusual and hard to understand today. It was designed to protect an accused woman from a husband’s jealousy by placing the matter in God’s hands. It was a way of keeping a suspicion from turning into violence, and it put the verdict in the hands of the God who sees all things.

The Nazirite vow is a different kind of consecration. Priests were born to their roles, but a Nazirite chose his. Any man or woman could set themselves apart for a time. The three signs of the vow, no grapes, uncut hair, and no contact with the dead, marked a life given wholly to God. It reminds us that holiness is available to everyone.

The blessing at the end is a gem. It has three lines, each longer than the one before, and each is a prayer for God’s favor: his protection, his face turned toward us, and his peace. The key phrase is “put my name upon the people.” The blessing is not Aaron’s. It is the LORD’s. The people are marked with his name, and the blessing is his gift to them.

STEP 5

Connection

Samson, Samuel, and John the Baptist were set apart as Nazirites or in a similar way. Paul took a vow of this kind (Acts 18:18). Jesus is the greater one who was wholly consecrated to the Father. Paul prays a version of the blessing in his letters (2 Corinthians 13:14; Philippians 4:7). Hebrews 7:1 says that Melchizedek blessed Abraham, and Jesus lifted his hands and blessed his disciples as he ascended (Luke 24:50-51).

STEP 6

Application

Read the blessing aloud, and receive it as a word spoken over you personally. Then speak it over someone you love.

Think about whether there is something you need to confess and repay.

Consider what it would mean to set aside something for a season so that you could give more to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pray the Aaronic blessing over yourself, slowly, in your own words.
- Ask him to put his name on you and make you a blessing.
- Pray the same blessing over someone you love.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 22

"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace."

NUMBERS 6:24-26

DAY 153 · WEEK 22

Psalm 90

Moses' psalm, God's eternity against human frailty

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 90. It is the only psalm attributed to Moses. Read it as a reflection by a man who has led a rebellious people for forty years and knows both God's eternity and human weakness.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 90 opens the fourth book of the Psalms. The title is "A Prayer of Moses, the man of God." If Moses wrote it, it comes from the wilderness years, when a whole generation died without entering the promised land. The sense of time passing, of lives cut short, and of God's anger against sin runs through it. It is placed here as a companion to the book of Numbers.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Lord, you have been our dwelling place in all generations" (v. 1).
2. "Before the mountains were brought forth, or ever you had formed the earth and the world, from everlasting to everlasting you are God" (v. 2).
3. "You return man to dust and say, Return, O children of man!" (v. 3).
4. "For a thousand years in your sight are but as yesterday when it is past, or as a watch in the night" (v. 4).
5. "The years of our life are seventy, or even by reason of strength eighty" (v. 10).
6. "So teach us to number our days that we may get a heart of wisdom" (v. 12).
7. "Satisfy us in the morning with your steadfast love, that we may rejoice and be glad all our days" (v. 14).

8 “Let the favor of the Lord our God be upon us, and establish the work of our hands upon us; yes, establish the work of our hands!” (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a surprising claim for a people with no home: “You have been our dwelling place.” Israel had no land and lived in tents. But Moses says that their true home was never a place. It was God. This is the first sentence of the psalm, and everything else depends on it.

Then comes a contrast between God’s eternity and human frailty. God is from everlasting to everlasting. We are like grass that sprouts in the morning and withers by evening. Moses does not say this to make us feel hopeless. He says it so that we see how much we depend on God.

The cause of our frailty is not only that we are creatures. It is that we are sinners. Verses 7 to 11 connect human mortality to God’s anger. “We are brought to an end by your anger.” Moses had watched a generation die in the wilderness because of unbelief, and he knows that death is not natural. It is a sign of judgment. Our secret sins are “in the light of your presence.”

But the psalm does not end with despair. It turns in verse 12, with a prayer: “Teach us to number our days.” The right response to our short lives is wisdom, living each day with an awareness of its limits. Then it asks for compassion: “Have pity on your servants.” It asks for joy in the morning, joy to match the years of affliction. And it ends with a request that the work of our hands might be established. God’s favor is what makes small and brief work last.

It is a good psalm to read at the start of a long book about the wilderness. It reminds us that the journey is brief, that God is our home, and that his steadfast love is the only thing that satisfies.

STEP 5

Connection

Peter quotes verse 4 when he says that “with the Lord one day is as a thousand years” (2 Peter 3:8). James says that life is “a mist that appears for a little time and then vanishes” (James 4:14). Paul teaches that death entered through sin and that Christ has defeated it (Romans 5:12; 1 Corinthians 15:54-57). Jesus said that in his Father’s house there are many rooms (John 14:2), and he is our dwelling place now.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself how many days you may have left, and what you most want to do with them. Pray verse 12 for yourself.

Think about the work you are doing right now. Ask God to establish it, and to make it last for his purposes.

Thank God that he is your dwelling place, even when you feel like a wanderer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for being your dwelling place in every season of life.
- Ask him to teach you to number your days and gain a heart of wisdom.
- Ask him to establish the work of your hands for his glory.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 22

"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace."

NUMBERS 6:24-26

DAY 154 · WEEK 22

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Numbers 6:24-26 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace."

NUMBERS 6:24-26

REST

Meditation

The Aaronic blessing is one of the oldest pieces of Scripture still used in worship. It has been said over God's people for three thousand years. Receive it as if it is spoken to you today.

"The LORD bless you and keep you." The blessing begins with God's goodness and protection. To keep means to guard and watch over, as a shepherd keeps his flock. It does not promise a life without trouble. It promises the one who keeps us in trouble.

"The LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you." The face of God shining is a picture of his favor and delight. A father's smile gives a child confidence. God's face, turned toward you in grace, is the deepest blessing there is.

“The LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace.” The picture is of God looking at you, lifting his face, and giving shalom. Peace here is not only calm. It means wholeness, the well-being of every part of life.

Notice that the name of the LORD stands at the start of each line. He is the one who blesses, and he does it by putting his name on his people. For Christians, this is fulfilled in Christ. In him, God’s face has shone on us (2 Corinthians 4:6), and he has made peace through the blood of his cross (Colossians 1:20).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the book of Numbers. You read about the census of Israel and the arrangement of the camp around the tabernacle, and you saw that God knows his people by name. You read about the Levites, who were given to God in place of the firstborn, and who carried the tabernacle with reverence. You read laws of purity and restitution, the Nazirite vow, and the blessing that God commanded Aaron to speak over his people. In Psalm 90, you heard Moses pray about the brevity of life and the eternity of God. The week taught that God orders and protects his people, that he claims them by substitution, and that he blesses them with his own name.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The camp was arranged around the tabernacle. What is at the center of your life, and how would your daily schedule change if God’s presence were at the center?

The Levites were taken in place of the firstborn. How does the idea of substitution deepen your understanding of what Christ did for you?

Psalm 90 asks, “Teach us to number our days.” What is one thing you would do differently if you took the shortness of life seriously?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for blessing and keeping you this week, naming one way.

Thank him for putting his name on his people.

Rest in his presence today.

DAY 155 · WEEK 23

Numbers 7:1-89

The offerings of the leaders, devotion in detail

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 89 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 7:1-89. This is the longest chapter in the book, and it records the same offering twelve times. Read it with patience, and ask why the Holy Spirit would give so much space to repetition.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The tabernacle has been set up and anointed. Now the twelve tribal leaders bring gifts for its dedication: carts and oxen for the Levites, and then, one leader per day for twelve days, an identical offering of silver and gold vessels, animals, and grain. It is the last event in the book before the departure from Sinai, and it is the longest chapter of Numbers. It ends with a short note about Moses hearing the voice of God from the mercy seat.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The leaders bring six covered wagons and twelve oxen as an offering (7:1-3).
2. God tells Moses to give the wagons to the Levites, according to their needs (7:4-9).
3. Each leader brings an offering on his own day: “Nahshon the son of Amminadab of the tribe of Judah” first (7:12).
4. Each offering is the same: a silver plate, a silver basin, a golden dish of incense, animals for burnt, sin, and peace offerings (7:13-17).
5. The text repeats the list for each of the twelve tribes (7:18-83).
6. The total is added up at the end (7:84-88).
7. The Kohathites receive no wagons, because their duty is to carry the holy things on their shoulders (7:9).

8 “And when Moses went into the tent of meeting to speak with the LORD, he heard the voice speaking to him from above the mercy seat that was on the ark of the testimony” (7:89).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The repetition in this chapter is the point. Each tribe brings exactly the same gift, even though some were large and some small, and some were wealthy and some poor. No one tries to outdo the others. No one is left out. The identical gifts say that every tribe has an equal share in the worship of God. Judah, the leading tribe, and Naphtali, one of the smallest, are written down with the same lines.

The chapter also shows that God notices every gift. Twelve times the same words are written out in full. A modern editor would have said “the other tribes did likewise.” But God gives each leader his own paragraph, because each gift is individually received and individually remembered. Nothing given to God is lost in a crowd.

The detail about the wagons is easy to miss. The leaders give the Levites what they need to do their work. The Levites in the families of Gershon and Merari get wagons and oxen, in proportion to their burden. The Kohathites, whose task is the holiest, get none, because the holy things must be carried on the shoulder. The offerings of the people serve the needs of the ministry, and every task has its own tools.

The chapter ends quietly with a verse that is easy to pass over: Moses enters the tent of meeting and hears the voice of God. This is the answer to the whole purpose of the tabernacle. All the gifts, the carts, the silver, and the animals lead to a place where God speaks to his servant. The worship and generosity of the people make room for God’s voice.

It may feel strange to read the same list twelve times. But treat it as a reminder that no act of devotion is trivial to God.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus praised the widow who gave two small coins, because she gave more than the rich (Mark 12:41-44). Paul wrote that “each of you should give what you have decided in your heart to give” (2 Corinthians 9:7), and that the church is a body in which every member matters (1 Corinthians 12). Hebrews 4:16 says that we can approach “the throne of grace” with confidence. Jesus speaks to us from heaven by his word.

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on whether you compare your giving to others. Ask God to make you content to give what he has put in your hand.

Remember that God notices what you do in secret. Offer something to him today that no one else will see.

Ask the Lord to speak to you through his Word, as he did to Moses.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you give without comparing yourself to others.
- Thank him that he remembers each gift.
- Thank him that he speaks to you through his Word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 23

"Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness."

PSALM 95:7-8

DAY 156 · WEEK 23

Numbers 8:1-10:36

The Levites consecrated; the cloud; the silver trumpets

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 85 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 8:1-10:36. This reading covers the lampstand, the consecration of the Levites, a second Passover, and the departure from Sinai. Notice the role of the cloud and the trumpets in guiding the people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the end of Israel's year at Sinai. In these chapters, God completes the preparations for the march. The lamps are lit, the Levites are set apart for service, and a second Passover is kept, with a provision for those who were unclean. The cloud and the silver trumpets give the signals to move. Then, on the twentieth day of the second month of the second year, the cloud lifts from the tabernacle and Israel leaves Sinai.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Aaron sets up the lamps to give light "in front of the lampstand" (8:1-4).
2. The Levites are cleansed with water, shaved, and presented, and the people lay their hands on them (8:5-13).
3. The Levites are "wholly given to me from among the people of Israel" (8:16).
4. The Passover is observed in the second year, and a second chance is given to those who were unclean or traveling (9:1-14).
5. The cloud covers the tabernacle by day and has the appearance of fire by night (9:15-16).
6. "At the command of the LORD they camped, and at the command of the LORD they set out" (9:23).
7. Two silver trumpets are made to call the congregation and to signal the march (10:1-10).

8 The ark leads the way, and Moses says, “Rise up, O LORD, and let your enemies be scattered” and “Return, O LORD, to the ten thousands of thousands of Israel” (10:33-36).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Levites’ consecration echoes the laying on of hands in the sacrifices. The people lay their hands on the Levites, as if to say, “These stand for us.” Then the Levites lay their hands on the bulls for the sin offering and burnt offering. The pattern is a chain of substitution: the people give the Levites, and the Levites give the animals. It shows how the gift of a servant leads back to the sacrifice that makes service possible.

The second Passover is a small, kind detail. Some men were unclean and could not keep the first Passover, and they ask Moses what to do. God answers by creating a make-up date, a second Passover a month later. The law shows a flexible grace. God does not want anyone to be left out of the meal because of circumstances they could not help.

The cloud is the centerpiece of this section. Israel does not set its own schedule. When the cloud lifts, they move, and when it stays, they stay, whether for two days, a month, or a year. The text says it three times, so we cannot miss it. It is hard to be led like this. It requires trust, patience, and a readiness to leave a comfortable place. But the people are guided by the presence of God himself.

The silver trumpets add voice to this guidance. They call the people together and signal war and feasts. Even the sound of the camp is arranged by God. And Moses’ words at the ark are a prayer: “Rise up, O LORD.” It is a battle prayer, but it is also a statement of faith. The LORD goes before his people, and they follow.

You are looking at the high point of Israel’s obedience. They have left Sinai in order, with the ark in front and the cloud above. The next chapter will show how quickly it goes wrong.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told his disciples, “Follow me” (Matthew 4:19), and he said that his sheep “hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me” (John 10:27). Paul writes that “all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God” (Romans 8:14). The ascension of Christ was accompanied by a cloud (Acts 1:9), and the Lord will return “with a cry of command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the sound of the trumpet of God” (1 Thessalonians 4:16).

STEP 6

Application

Think about a place where you are waiting for God to move. Ask him to give you patience and trust.

If you are in a season of change, pray that God would show you whether to stay or go.

Pray Moses' words from 10:35-36 as a prayer for your church and your family.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to lead you by his Spirit and Word.
- Tell him where you need patience to wait or courage to move.
- Pray "Rise up, O LORD" over the road ahead.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 23

"Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness."

PSALM 95:7-8

DAY 157 · WEEK 23

Numbers 11:1-12:16

Complaining; quail and plague; Miriam's leprosy

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 11:1-12:16. The march begins, and within days the people are complaining. Read these two chapters as a portrait of grumbling, and notice who says it, and what God does in response.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has left Sinai with the ark in front and the cloud above. Three days later, the complaining starts. Chapter 11 describes three crises: general grumbling that leads to fire, a craving for meat that leads to quail and a plague, and Moses' own exhaustion. Chapter 12 describes an attack on Moses from within his own family. The chapters show that the greatest danger to Israel is not Egypt behind them or Canaan ahead, but the hearts of the people themselves.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And the people complained in the hearing of the LORD about their misfortunes, and when the LORD heard it, his anger was kindled" (11:1).
2. Fire from the LORD burns at the edge of the camp, until Moses prays and it dies down (11:1-3).
3. The "rabble" among them crave meat, and the Israelites say, "Oh that we had meat to eat! We remember the fish we ate in Egypt that cost nothing" (11:4-5).
4. Moses says to God, "Why have you dealt ill with your servant?... I am not able to carry all this people alone" (11:11-14).
5. God has Moses gather seventy elders, and he puts some of the Spirit that was on Moses on them, and they prophesy (11:16-25).

6. Eldad and Medad prophesy in the camp, and Moses says, “Would that all the LORD’s people were prophets” (11:26-29).
7. Quail come in, and the people gorge, and a plague breaks out (11:31-35).
8. Miriam and Aaron speak against Moses. “Now the man Moses was very meek, more than all people who were on the face of the earth” (12:1-3). Miriam becomes leprous, and Moses prays for her (12:10-15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The pattern of Israel’s grumbling is a mirror for our own hearts. The people forget the slavery and remember only the food. They say that Egypt’s fish was free. It was not. It cost them their freedom. This is one of the most common human mistakes: remembering the pleasures of an old life and forgetting its chains. Nostalgia is a form of unbelief.

The craving for meat is not wrong because meat is wrong. It is wrong because the people had the manna, God’s daily provision, and called it worthless. They were despising the gift, and they were despising the giver. When God gives them what they want, in excess, it becomes a judgment. “He gave them what they asked, but sent a wasting disease among them,” as Psalm 106:15 says. Sometimes the worst thing God can do is give us what we demand.

Moses’ own complaint is notable. He is not rebuked as the people are, but his prayer shows how heavy leadership is. God’s answer is to share the load: he puts the Spirit on seventy elders. The burden is not removed. It is shared. And Moses’ response to Eldad and Medad is one of the great statements of the Old Testament: “Would that all the LORD’s people were prophets, that the LORD would put his Spirit on them!” It is a prayer that waits for the new covenant.

Chapter 12 shows how even those closest to Moses can fall. Miriam and Aaron criticize Moses’ wife and claim that they should share his authority. The text says that Moses was very meek, and he does not defend himself. God defends him. God speaks to Moses “face to face,” unlike other prophets, and Miriam is struck. The chapter shows how seriously God takes the authority of the one he appoints. And Moses prays for her healing, a beautiful example of a meek man who returns good for evil.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that these things “took place as examples for us, that we might not desire evil as they did” (1 Corinthians 10:6, 10), and he specifically warns against grumbling. Peter echoes Moses’ wish at Pentecost, when the Spirit is poured out on all flesh (Acts 2:17-18). Hebrews

3:1-6 compares Moses' faithfulness "as a servant" with Christ's faithfulness "as a son." Jesus is the meek one who prayed for those who wronged him (Luke 23:34).

STEP 6

Application

Notice your own grumbling this week. What are you remembering from the past that you have forgotten the cost of?

Thank God for a specific gift that you have taken for granted, the manna in your own life.

Pray for a leader you know, and ask God to share the burden of leadership with others.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have grumbled about what God has given.
- Ask him to teach you gratitude for your daily bread.
- Thank him for Jesus, who gives the Spirit to all his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 23

"Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness."

PSALM 95:7-8

DAY 158 · WEEK 23

Numbers 13:1-14:45

The twelve spies; the faithless report; forty years

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 13:1-14:45. This is the turning point of the book and one of the saddest chapters in the Old Testament. Read it as the story of a failure of faith, and note carefully what the people say, and what God says in reply.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has come to the edge of Canaan, at Kadesh in the wilderness of Paran. God tells Moses to send twelve men, one from each tribe, to explore the land. They go for forty days and return with a report. Ten say the land is good but its people are too strong. Two, Joshua and Caleb, say that God will give it to them. The people believe the ten. What follows is the decisive failure of the exodus generation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God says, “Send men to spy out the land of Canaan, which I am giving to the people of Israel” (13:2).
2. The spies bring back a cluster of grapes so large that it is carried on a pole by two men (13:23).
3. All twelve agree: “It flows with milk and honey” (13:27).
4. Ten report: “We are not able to go up against the people, for they are stronger than we… we seemed to ourselves like grasshoppers” (13:31-33).
5. Caleb says, “Let us go up at once and occupy it, for we are well able to overcome it” (13:30).

6. The people weep and say, “Would that we had died in the land of Egypt!” and propose to choose a leader and go back (14:1-4).

7. Moses pleads for the people, appealing to God’s name: “The LORD is slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love” (14:13-19).

8. God pardons them, but says that none of the men who saw his signs and yet tested him ten times shall see the land. Their children will enter, after forty years of wandering (14:20-35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sin here is not caution. It is unbelief. God had already said that he was giving them the land. The spies were not sent to decide whether to go, but to see what God was giving. When ten of them look at the land and then look at themselves, they forget God. Their report shifts from “the land flows with milk and honey” to “the land devours its inhabitants.” And their self-image shrinks: “we seemed to ourselves like grasshoppers.” Fear distorts how we see ourselves and how we see God.

Joshua and Caleb saw the same land and the same giants. The difference was not in what they saw, but in what they believed about God. Caleb says, “we are well able,” and Joshua says, “the LORD is with us; do not fear them.” Faith does not deny the giants. It remembers who is bigger.

The people’s reaction is a tragedy. They weep all night. They say they wish they had died in Egypt, and they even say that God brought them out because he hates them (Deuteronomy 1:27). They call good evil. In a few hours, they undo the whole exodus in their minds.

Moses’ intercession is a high point. He does not argue that Israel deserves mercy. He argues from God’s own character, quoting the words of Exodus 34:6-7. And God does pardon the people, but he does not remove the consequences. The generation that refused to enter will not enter. Forgiveness and discipline are both real.

The last scene shows how unbelief hardens into presumption. When told they will not enter, the people suddenly decide to attack on their own. Without God, they are defeated. Obedience delayed is not the same as obedience. They had refused to go when God said go, and now they went when God said no.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 3 and 4 use this story as a warning to the church. “Take care, brothers, lest there be in any of you an evil, unbelieving heart, leading you to fall away from the living God” (Hebrews 3:12). The generation “were unable to enter because of unbelief” (Hebrews 3:19). The promise of rest still stands, and Jesus, whose name is the same as Joshua’s, leads us in. Paul says that these events were written down for our instruction (1 Corinthians 10:11).

STEP 6

Application

Ask what giant you are facing, and whether you are seeing it through your own eyes or God’s promise.

Is there something God has told you to do that you are delaying? Obey today, not later.

Pray for the courage of Joshua and Caleb, to speak the truth even when the crowd is afraid.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God where you have been looking at giants instead of promises.
- Confess your unbelief and ask for a spirit like Caleb’s.
- Thank Jesus for leading his people into rest.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 23

“Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness.”

PSALM 95:7-8

DAY 159 · WEEK 23

Psalm 95

Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 95. Yesterday's chapter described a generation that hardened its heart. Today's psalm reads that story as a warning to us. Read it aloud, and notice the sudden change of tone in verse 7.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 95 is a psalm of worship that has been sung in the church's morning prayer for centuries. It starts with a joyful call to come and sing, and then shifts at the end into an urgent warning drawn from Numbers 14. The psalm does not name its author, but Hebrews 4:7 attributes it to David. The setting is the worship of the gathered congregation, who are reminded that praise must go with obedience.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh come, let us sing to the LORD; let us make a joyful noise to the rock of our salvation!" (v. 1).
2. "Let us come into his presence with thanksgiving; let us make a joyful noise to him with songs of praise!" (v. 2).
3. "For the LORD is a great God, and a great King above all gods" (v. 3).
4. "In his hand are the depths of the earth; the heights of the mountains are his also" (v. 4).
5. "Oh come, let us worship and bow down; let us kneel before the LORD, our Maker!" (v. 6).
6. "For he is our God, and we are the people of his pasture, and the sheep of his hand" (v. 7).

7. “Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness” (vv. 7-8).

8. “Therefore I swore in my wrath, They shall not enter my rest” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm has two halves, and the contrast is meant to startle us. The first half, verses 1 to 7a, is full of praise: singing, shouting, thanksgiving, bowing down. The second half is a warning. The same God who is a great king and a good shepherd is also the God who swore that a generation would not enter his rest. The psalmist places the two side by side because true worship includes both.

Worship, in this psalm, has an inward and an outward side. It is noisy and joyful, and it is also quiet and obedient. “Let us kneel before the LORD” and “if you hear his voice.” It is not enough to sing loudly. The test of worship is whether we listen.

The word “today” is the key. It is a present-tense word. “Today, if you hear his voice” does not refer to the past or the future. The wilderness generation heard his voice at Sinai and then refused. The psalmist says that the same opportunity is offered to every generation. It is as urgent now as then.

The phrase “do not harden your hearts” implies that hearts can be hardened or softened by our own choices. It is a process, not an event. Each time we ignore God’s voice, it becomes easier to ignore the next time. Each time we obey, our hearts become more sensitive. We are always moving in one direction or the other.

And “my rest” is the goal of the whole journey. The land was a picture of that rest, but the real thing is deeper: to be at home with God. The sad truth is that people can sing about it, and still miss it.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 3:7-4:13 is an extended meditation on this psalm. The writer applies it to Christians: “Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts.” He says that a Sabbath rest remains for the people of God, and “let us therefore strive to enter that rest” (Hebrews 4:9-11). Jesus invites, “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest” (Matthew 11:28).

STEP 6

Application

Read Psalm 95 aloud as an act of worship. Include the warning.

Ask whether there is a place where you have been ignoring God's voice. Today is the day to listen.

Thank God that the rest he promises is found in Christ, and ask him to soften any hardness in your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you want to hear his voice today.
- Ask him to keep your heart soft and keep you from unbelief.
- Thank him for the rest that is yours in Jesus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 23

"Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness."

PSALM 95:7-8

DAY 160 · WEEK 23

Psalm 96

Sing to the LORD a new song

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 96. Where yesterday's psalm warned, today's celebrates. Read it as a missionary song, and notice how many times it speaks of "all the earth," "the nations," and "the peoples."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 96 is closely related to a song of David recorded in 1 Chronicles 16, sung when the ark was brought to Jerusalem. It begins with the call to "sing to the LORD a new song," and it widens quickly to include the whole world. In the context of Numbers, with its story of a people who failed in unbelief, the psalm lifts the eyes toward a future in which every nation praises the LORD.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh sing to the LORD a new song; sing to the LORD, all the earth!" (v. 1).
2. "Sing to the LORD, bless his name; tell of his salvation from day to day" (v. 2).
3. "Declare his glory among the nations, his marvelous works among all the peoples!" (v. 3).
4. "For great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised; he is to be feared above all gods" (v. 4).
5. "For all the gods of the peoples are worthless idols, but the LORD made the heavens" (v. 5).
6. "Ascribe to the LORD, O families of the peoples, ascribe to the LORD glory and strength!" (v. 7).
7. "Worship the LORD in the splendor of holiness; tremble before him, all the earth!" (v. 9).

8 “Say among the nations, The LORD reigns!... He will judge the peoples with equity” (vv. 10-13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This psalm is a call to worship that is also a call to mission. The singing is not meant to stay in Israel. It is to be declared “among the nations.” The salvation of the LORD is to be told “from day to day.” The God of Israel is not a tribal god. He made the heavens, and he is the only true God.

The “new song” is the response to a new act of salvation. Each generation has to sing for itself what God has done. It is not enough to repeat the old songs only as history. We need to make them new by remembering and applying them to our own situation.

The contrast between the LORD and the gods of the peoples is sharp. Verse 5 uses a Hebrew pun: the word for “idols” sounds like the word for “nothings.” The gods of the nations are worthless things, and the LORD made the heavens. This is the same contrast Israel had just ignored in the wilderness. The psalm urges the nations to turn from nothing to everything.

The psalm ends with creation joining in. The heavens, the earth, the sea, the fields, and the trees of the forest all rejoice, because the LORD is coming to judge the earth. The coming of God is good news for the world. He will judge with equity and truth. In a world full of injustice, this is a hope worth singing about.

After reading about Israel’s complaining, the psalm is a rebuke and an invitation. Israel’s calling was to sing, to witness, and to bring the nations in. The failure of the wilderness is not the end of the story. God will still be praised in all the earth.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus sent his disciples to “make disciples of all nations” (Matthew 28:19). Revelation 5:9 and 7:9 show a multitude from every nation praising the Lamb, singing a “new song.” Paul says that creation “will be set free from its bondage to corruption” (Romans 8:21). The coming of the Lord to judge the earth is the Christian’s hope (Acts 17:31; Revelation 19).

STEP 6

Application

Sing or read this psalm aloud. Ask God to give you a new song for something he has done recently.

Pray for a missionary or a nation that has not heard the gospel.

Tell someone this week about something God has done for you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Sing or speak to the LORD a new song, in your own words.
- Ask him to make you bold to tell of his salvation.
- Pray “Come, Lord Jesus” to judge the earth in righteousness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 23

“Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness.”

PSALM 95:7-8

DAY 161 · WEEK 23

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 95:7-8 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness."

PSALM 95:7-8

REST

Meditation

This verse is a warning and an invitation in one breath. It was written to people who had a long history of hearing God's voice and refusing it, and it is quoted three times in the book of Hebrews to address Christians.

"Today." The word is the center of the verse. God does not speak only to those who lived long ago. He speaks today. There is a sense of urgency in the word, and also of mercy. As long as it is called "today," there is still time to respond.

"If you hear his voice." Hearing is more than sound. It is the attention that leads to obedience. Israel heard God's voice at Sinai, and they trembled, and still they refused at Kadesh. The question is not whether God speaks. It is whether we will listen.

“Do not harden your hearts.” The picture is of something soft being made hard, as clay left in the sun. It is a gradual process, and it happens through small refusals. Each time we say no to what we know God is asking, the next no comes easier.

“As at Meribah, as on the day at Massah.” Meribah means “quarreling” and Massah means “testing.” These places became names for Israel’s failure. The warning is that we can give our own lives names like these if we are not careful.

For the Christian, the verse is a call to stay close to Christ. “Exhort one another every day, as long as it is called ‘today,’ that none of you may be hardened by the deceitfulness of sin” (Hebrews 3:13).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed Israel’s departure from Sinai. You read about the offerings of the tribal leaders, the consecration of the Levites, the second Passover, and the cloud that led the people by day and night. You watched the march begin with order and then break down in complaining, as the people longed for the food of Egypt and Miriam and Aaron challenged Moses. You read the story of the twelve spies, the unbelief of the people, and the judgment that a whole generation would die in the wilderness. In the Psalms, you read the warning of Psalm 95 and the missionary song of Psalm 96. The week taught that unbelief is the root of rebellion, that God’s patience is real but not endless, and that the answer is to listen today.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The ten spies saw the same land as Joshua and Caleb. What shaped the difference between their reports, and what shapes how you see your own challenges?

Hebrews says that Christ is the one who leads his people into God’s rest. How does Jesus succeed where Joshua and Moses could not?

Where might you be hardening your heart today? Write down one thing God has asked of you and what it would look like to obey today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to hear his voice today, and ask him to soften any hard place in you.

Ask him for the faith of Caleb and Joshua.

Thank Jesus for leading you into his rest.

DAY 162 · WEEK 24

Numbers 15:1-16:50

Offerings; Korah's rebellion against God's appointed

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 15:1-16:50. Chapter 15 gives laws that look ahead to the land. Chapter 16 tells the story of Korah's rebellion. Read the first chapter as a reassurance, and the second as a warning.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the disaster at Kadesh, the story slows. Chapter 15 is a surprising pause: God gives laws for offerings "when you come into the land," which is a promise that his plan has not been cancelled. Chapter 16 then shows a new challenge to Moses and Aaron, led by Korah, a Levite, with Dathan and Abiram of Reuben, and 250 leaders. They object that Moses and Aaron have taken too much to themselves.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When you come into the land you are to inhabit, which I am giving you" (15:2) introduces laws about offerings.
2. The same law applies to the native and to the sojourner (15:14-16).
3. Unintentional sins can be forgiven with a sacrifice, but "the person who does anything with a high hand… reviles the LORD" (15:22-31).
4. A man is put to death for gathering sticks on the Sabbath (15:32-36).
5. The people are told to put tassels on their garments, "that you may remember all the commandments of the LORD" (15:37-41).
6. Korah says, "You have gone too far! For all in the congregation are holy, every one of them" (16:3).

7. Moses says that the LORD will show who is his, and the ground opens and swallows Korah's household (16:28-33).

8. The next day, the people grumble again and a plague strikes. Aaron stands with the censer "between the dead and the living," and the plague stops (16:41-50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 15 is a quiet promise in the midst of judgment. Just after God says that a generation will die in the wilderness, he gives laws that begin "when you come into the land." The children will enter. God's purposes are not defeated by the unbelief of the parents. It is a lesson to hold on to when we fail: God's plan outlasts our failures.

The distinction between unintentional sin and the sin "with a high hand" is important. A person who sins in ignorance can find forgiveness through a sacrifice. But someone who knowingly defies God is despising his word. The story of the Sabbath-breaker, who deliberately and openly broke the commandment, illustrates it. The tassels on the garments are a counterweight: a simple, visible reminder to obey. God knows we forget, and he gives us ways to remember.

Korah's rebellion is a different kind of sin. His claim sounds democratic: "All the congregation are holy." And it is true that all Israel was called to be holy. But Korah is using that truth to attack the order God had established. He does not want holiness. He wants the priesthood. Moses' response is telling. He falls on his face. He does not defend himself, but leaves the matter to the LORD. And the test is a matter of approach: who may come near to God? God himself must choose.

The earth opens, and the rebels fall into Sheol alive. It is a terrifying judgment, and it shows how seriously God takes the offices he has set up. But the very next morning, the whole congregation complains again, accusing Moses and Aaron of killing the people of the LORD. They have learned nothing. Then comes the beautiful image of Aaron, the priest they had just rejected, running into the midst of the plague with a censer of incense and standing between the dead and the living. The plague stops. The mediator they scorned saves them.

STEP 5

Connection

Jude 11 warns against the "rebellion of Korah." Hebrews 5:4 says that no one takes the honor of the priesthood for himself, but only when called by God, as Aaron was. Jesus is the greater priest who stands between the living and the dead, not with a censer but with his own blood (Hebrews 9:12). Paul says that "there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus" (1 Timothy 2:5).

STEP 6

Application

Think about the tassels. What is one simple reminder you can put in your daily life to help you remember God's commands?

Examine whether any grumbling about leaders in your life has a root of pride.

Thank God for the mediator who stands between you and judgment.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for being the mediator who stands between the living and the dead.

Ask him to keep you from the pride of Korah.

Ask him to help you remember his commands in all that you do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 24

"Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture."

PSALM 100:3

DAY 163 · WEEK 24

Numbers 17:1-19:22

Aaron's rod buds; priestly dues; the red heifer

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 78 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 17:1-19:22. These chapters finish the story of the challenge to Aaron, describe the duties of the priests and Levites, and give the strange law of the red heifer. Read the middle chapter for its theme of provision, and the last for its theme of cleansing.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the rebellion of Korah, the question of who may approach God has to be settled for good. Chapter 17 does this with a sign: twelve staffs are placed before the ark overnight, and only Aaron's blossoms. Chapter 18 describes what the priests and Levites receive for their support, and chapter 19 describes a ritual for cleansing from contact with the dead, using the ashes of a red heifer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Twelve staffs, one for each tribe, are laid before the LORD in the tent of meeting (17:1-7).
2. "Behold, the staff of Aaron for the house of Levi had sprouted and put forth buds and produced blossoms, and it bore ripe almonds" (17:8).
3. The staff is put back before the testimony as a sign to the rebels (17:10).
4. The people cry, "Behold, we perish, we are lost, we are all lost!" (17:12).
5. The priests and Levites have no inheritance in the land: "I am your portion and your inheritance among the people of Israel" (18:20).
6. The Levites receive the tithe, and they give a tithe of the tithe to the priests (18:21-32).

7. A red heifer without blemish is slaughtered outside the camp, and burned with cedar, hyssop, and scarlet yarn (19:1-10).
8. The ashes are mixed with water to cleanse anyone who has touched a dead body (19:11-22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Aaron's staff is a picture of life from death. A dry stick, cut from a tree, put in a dark tent overnight, bursts into buds, flowers, and ripe almonds. It is a miracle that shows the choice of God, and it also gives a symbol of resurrection. The staff was dead wood, and it lived. The one God has chosen is the one who brings life.

The sign settles the question, and it also shows the people's fear. They had been grumbling that Moses and Aaron were killing them, and now they say, "We are lost!" The proper answer to that fear is in the next chapter, where God sets out the provision for the priesthood. The priests will bear the iniquity of the sanctuary. They stand between God's holiness and the people's sin, so that the people do not die by coming too near.

The statement in 18:20 is one of the loveliest in the book. The priests and Levites will have no land. "I am your portion and your inheritance." It sounds like a loss, but it is the greatest gift. The ones closest to God have God himself. The psalmist later says, "The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup" (Psalm 16:5).

The red heifer is the most puzzling ritual in the law. It involves a spotless animal sacrificed outside the camp, burned, and its ashes used for cleansing. It is a rite for dealing with death, the great defilement. A priest who prepares the ashes becomes unclean himself, a paradox that the rabbis later noted. The one who cleanses others is made unclean by the work.

The common thread through these chapters is that God provides what is needed to live in his presence. He provides a priest who is chosen and living, a portion that is himself, and a cleansing for the effects of death. Each of these looks ahead to Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the one who rose from the dead, the true budding rod. Hebrews 9:13-14 says, "If the blood of goats and bulls, and the sprinkling of defiled persons with the ashes of a heifer, sanctify for the purification of the flesh, how much more will the blood of Christ... purify our conscience from dead works." Hebrews 13:12 says that Jesus suffered outside the gate. Paul says that Christ is "the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep" (1 Corinthians 15:20).

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on the statement, “I am your portion.” Ask whether God himself is enough for you.

Thank God for the life that comes out of death, in Christ and in your own story.

Read Hebrews 9:13-14 and pray for the cleansing of your conscience from dead works.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what it means that he is your portion and inheritance.
- Thank him for the life that comes out of death in Jesus.
- Ask him to cleanse your conscience and let you live without fear.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 24

“Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture.”

PSALM 100:3

DAY 164 · WEEK 24

Numbers 20:1-21:35

Miriam dies; the rock; the bronze serpent, look and live

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 20:1-21:35. This reading includes Moses' great failure at Meribah, the death of Miriam and Aaron, and the story of the bronze serpent. Read slowly, and notice how one story leads into the next.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Thirty-eight years have passed, and a new generation stands at Kadesh again. The first generation has largely died. Miriam dies, the people complain about water, and Moses and Aaron sin at the rock. Edom refuses passage. Aaron dies on Mount Hor. Then Israel complains again, and God sends fiery serpents, and then provides a way of healing. The chapters end with the first victories in Transjordan.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Miriam dies and is buried at Kadesh (20:1).
2. The people quarrel with Moses about water, saying, "Why have you brought the assembly of the LORD into this wilderness, that we should die here?" (20:3-5).
3. God says, "Take the staff... and tell the rock before their eyes to yield its water" (20:8).
4. Moses says, "Hear now, you rebels: shall we bring water for you out of this rock?" and strikes the rock twice (20:10-11).
5. God says, "Because you did not believe in me, to uphold me as holy in the eyes of the people of Israel, therefore you shall not bring this assembly into the land" (20:12).
6. Aaron dies on Mount Hor, and his garments are put on Eleazar (20:22-29).

7. The people speak against God and Moses: “We loathe this worthless food.” The LORD sends fiery serpents (21:4-6).

8. God says, “Make a fiery serpent and set it on a pole, and everyone who is bitten, when he sees it, shall live” (21:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sin of Moses at the rock is subtle, and it is easy to underestimate. God told him to speak to the rock. Instead, Moses struck it twice, and he said, “Shall we bring water for you out of this rock?” He took the credit that belonged to God. He struck instead of speaking, repeating an earlier command from Exodus 17. And he spoke in anger. The punishment seems severe, but leaders are held to a higher standard, and Moses had misrepresented God to the people. God had described himself as gracious, and Moses showed him as harsh.

The point is a sobering one: even Moses, the meekest man on earth, could fail. No human leader can bring the people into the promised land. The law cannot do it. Only another Joshua, only a greater leader, can.

The bronze serpent is among the strangest and most important stories in the Bible. The people have been bitten by snakes because of their sin. God does not remove the snakes. Instead, he gives a remedy that requires only a look. The cure is a serpent on a pole, the image of the very thing that is killing them. The ones who look live. There is no medicine, no effort, no payment. The simplest act of faith saves.

It is a story about how salvation works. The people had to believe that looking at a bronze snake would heal them. It is foolish by any natural reasoning. But God’s cure is often a matter of faith in his word, not an act of strength. “Everyone who is bitten, when he sees it, shall live.”

The progress from the death of Aaron to the lifting of the serpent to the first victories shows that God’s work continues even when leaders fail and die. The people move on toward the land, led by a God who does not die.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “As Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, so must the Son of Man be lifted up, that whoever believes in him may have eternal life” (John 3:14-15). The cross is the pole, and looking is believing. Paul says, “Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us” (Galatians 3:13). 1 Corinthians 10:4 says that the rock was Christ, who was struck once and now gives living water freely (John 7:37-38).

STEP 6

Application

Think about what it means to “look and live.” Spend a few minutes looking to Christ on the cross.

Ask whether you have ever taken credit for something God did. Give it back.

Pray for leaders who have failed, and thank God that his work does not depend on any one person.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Look to Jesus lifted up, and tell him what you need healed.
- Confess where you have taken credit that belongs to God.
- Thank him that his work goes on despite our failure.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 24

“Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture.”

PSALM 100:3

DAY 165 · WEEK 24

Numbers 22:1-24:25

Balaam, God's sovereignty over a false prophet

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 22:1-24:25. This is the story of Balaam, the prophet hired to curse Israel who can only bless them. It is full of irony and humor, and also one of the most important prophecies of the Messiah in the Old Testament. Notice who sees what.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has camped on the plains of Moab, east of the Jordan, opposite Jericho. Balak, the king of Moab, is afraid of them. He hires Balaam, a diviner from Mesopotamia, to curse Israel. God will not let him. Balaam goes, and three times he tries to curse, and three times he blesses. The story is told from a distance. Israel never hears of it, but God is fighting for them without their knowledge.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Balak says, "He whom you bless is blessed, and he whom you curse is cursed" (22:6).
2. God tells Balaam, "You shall not go with them. You shall not curse the people, for they are blessed" (22:12).
3. Balaam goes with Balak's men, and the donkey sees the angel of the LORD three times before Balaam does (22:21-35).
4. The donkey speaks: "What have I done to you, that you have struck me these three times?" (22:28).
5. Balaam says, "I cannot go beyond the command of the LORD my God to do less or more" (22:18).

6. “God is not man, that he should lie, or a son of man, that he should change his mind” (23:19).
7. “He has not beheld misfortune in Jacob, nor has he seen trouble in Israel. The LORD their God is with them” (23:21).
8. “I see him, but not now; I behold him, but not near: a star shall come out of Jacob, and a scepter shall rise out of Israel” (24:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The story of Balaam is comic and serious at the same time. A prophet-for-hire, who is hoping for a large payment, is outwitted by his own donkey. The animal sees the angel of the LORD, and the professional seer does not. He is more eager for money than for truth. The irony is complete when the donkey speaks and Balaam answers it as though it were normal to argue with a donkey.

The deeper point is that no one can curse those whom God has blessed. Balak thinks that the right words, from the right person, in the right place, can turn God’s favor away. But God’s blessing is not a thing to be manipulated. “How can I curse whom God has not cursed?” (23:8). The blessing was given in the covenant with Abraham, and it will not be undone by any spell.

The oracle in 23:19 is among the clearest statements of God’s faithfulness: “God is not man, that he should lie.” He does not change his mind the way people do. When he promises, he does it. The people do not know any of this is happening, which is the beauty of it. While Israel sleeps in their tents, God defends them.

The last oracle, in 24:17, is the high point. Balaam, who came to curse, ends by announcing a coming king: “a star shall come out of Jacob, and a scepter shall rise out of Israel.” It looks ahead to David, who crushed Moab, and beyond David to the final King. The oracle is spoken by a pagan prophet, whose own heart is not changed. God can use anyone to speak his word, even one who does not love him.

The tragedy of Balaam is that he knew all this and still ended badly. In the next chapter, you will see how Balaam’s counsel led Israel into sin.

STEP 5

Connection

The magi who followed a star to Bethlehem (Matthew 2:2) probably knew this prophecy. Jesus is called “the bright morning star” in Revelation 22:16. Paul says that “if God is for us, who can be against us?” (Romans 8:31), and “nothing… will be able to separate us from the

love of God" (Romans 8:38-39). Peter and Jude warn about the way of Balaam, which loves gain from wrongdoing (2 Peter 2:15; Jude 11).

STEP 6

Application

Remember that no curse can undo what God has blessed in Christ. Take comfort in that if you are afraid.

Ask whether you are ever more concerned with reward than with truth, like Balaam.

Thank God that he fights for you even when you are unaware of it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that those he has blessed cannot be cursed.
- Thank him for the Star who came out of Jacob.
- Ask him to keep you from loving gain more than truth.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 24

"Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture."

PSALM 100:3

DAY 166 · WEEK 24

Psalm 99

The LORD reigns; holy is he

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 99. This is the last of a short series of psalms that proclaim "the LORD reigns." Read it for its repeated refrain, "Holy is he," and notice how Moses, Aaron, and Samuel appear.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 99 is a psalm of praise to the LORD as king. It has three sections, each ending with a refrain about God's holiness. Unlike the more joyful psalms, this one stresses awe and reverence. It appears here because the story of Numbers has shown what happens when people forget that the God who lives among them is holy. It also mentions Moses and Aaron, the leaders of the wilderness generation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD reigns; let the peoples tremble! He sits enthroned upon the cherubim; let the earth quake!" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD is great in Zion; he is exalted over all the peoples" (v. 2).
3. "Let them praise your great and awesome name! Holy is he!" (v. 3).
4. "The King in his might loves justice. You have established equity; you have executed justice and righteousness in Jacob" (v. 4).
5. "Exalt the LORD our God; worship at his footstool! Holy is he!" (v. 5).
6. "Moses and Aaron were among his priests, Samuel also was among those who called upon his name" (v. 6).
7. "You were a forgiving God to them, but an avenger of their wrongdoings" (v. 8).

8 “Exalt the LORD our God, and worship at his holy mountain; for the LORD our God is holy!” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The refrain, “Holy is he,” gives the psalm its shape. The first section celebrates God’s rule over the nations, the second his love of justice, and the third his dealings with his people in history. Each ends with the same note. Holiness is not one attribute among many. It is the character that sets God apart from everything else, the quality that makes his power safe and his justice trustworthy.

It is notable that holiness and justice go together here. The “King in his might loves justice.” A holy God is not just distant and awesome. He cares about equity. His holiness shows itself in how he rules, which is fairly and truly.

The third section is the most important for this unit. It remembers Moses, Aaron, and Samuel, who called on the LORD, and says that he answered them. He spoke to them in the pillar of cloud. This is a reference to the wilderness generation. The psalm then says something that holds together the whole book of Numbers: “You were a forgiving God to them, but an avenger of their wrongdoings.” Both are true. God forgave Israel at Kadesh, and God also let a generation die in the wilderness. He is merciful, and he is holy. Neither cancels the other.

This is a difficult balance to keep. We tend to emphasize one side and neglect the other. The psalm holds both. It encourages us to approach God as forgiving and to remember that he is holy. This is exactly what Moses prayed in Exodus 34. The same pairing appears in the apostles: grace and truth, kindness and severity.

After a week of reading about people who tested God, it is good to end with a psalm that tells us to worship him at his footstool.

STEP 5

Connection

In Isaiah 6, the seraphim cry, “Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts,” and John says that Isaiah saw Christ’s glory (John 12:41). Revelation 4:8 repeats the cry before the throne. Paul says, “Note then the kindness and the severity of God” (Romans 11:22). Peter writes, “You shall be holy, for I am holy” (1 Peter 1:16). Hebrews 12:28-29 calls us to worship with reverence and awe.

STEP 6

Application

Read the psalm aloud, and pause at each “Holy is he.” Think about what holiness means to you.

Ask whether you have emphasized God’s mercy at the expense of his holiness, or the other way around.

Thank God for his forgiveness, and ask him to make you holy.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship the LORD as holy, in your own words.
- Thank him that he forgives and is also just.
- Ask him to teach you reverence and awe.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 24

“Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture.”

PSALM 100:3

DAY 167 · WEEK 24

Psalm 100

Make a joyful noise, all the earth as God's people

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 100. It is one of the shortest and most familiar psalms. Read it slowly, as a closing song for the week, and notice the commands and the reasons.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 100 is titled "A Psalm for giving thanks." It was probably sung when worshipers entered the temple courts with their thank offerings, like the thanksgiving offerings of Leviticus 7. It is brief, with only five verses. It has been sung by Christians for centuries, often as a call to worship at the start of a service. It ends the series of "the LORD reigns" psalms with an invitation for the whole earth to join in.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Make a joyful noise to the LORD, all the earth!" (v. 1).
2. "Serve the LORD with gladness! Come into his presence with singing!" (v. 2).
3. "Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture" (v. 3).
4. "Enter his gates with thanksgiving, and his courts with praise! Give thanks to him; bless his name!" (v. 4).
5. "For the LORD is good; his steadfast love endures forever, and his faithfulness to all generations" (v. 5).
6. There are seven commands: make a joyful noise, serve, come, know, enter, give thanks, bless.

7. There are three reasons: he is God and our maker, he is our shepherd, and he is good, loving, and faithful.

8. The psalm begins with “all the earth” and ends with “all generations.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a lesson in worship. It tells us what to do, and why. The commands are about joy, gladness, singing, thanksgiving, and praise. Worship is not meant to be a grim duty. It is meant to be glad service. The word “serve” in verse 2 is the same word used for the Levites’ work. All of life can be service, and the right attitude for it is gladness.

The reasons come in verse 3 and verse 5. First, “Know that the LORD, he is God.” Everything starts with who he is. Then, “It is he who made us, and we are his.” We did not make ourselves, and we do not belong to ourselves. This is a freeing thought. It means that we are not responsible for creating our own meaning. We were made, and we are his.

The image of sheep is especially fitting after reading Numbers. Israel were a flock, led by the cloud and the shepherd’s staff of Moses. Like sheep, they wandered, complained, and got into trouble. But they had a shepherd, and the psalm reminds us that we do, too. The one who leads is good.

The last verse gives three words that sum up God’s character: good, loving, and faithful. “His steadfast love endures forever” is the refrain of the whole Old Testament. It is the word used in Exodus 34:6, the name of God in the wilderness. The people failed again and again, but his love did not.

And the psalm is for everyone: “all the earth.” The church has always taken this seriously. The God of Israel is the God of the nations, and all are invited into his gates.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I am the good shepherd” (John 10:11), and “I will build my church” (Matthew 16:18). Peter says that believers “were straying like sheep, but have now returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls” (1 Peter 2:25). Paul says that all things were created through Christ and for him (Colossians 1:16). Revelation 7:9-10 shows people from every nation joining the worship around the throne.

STEP 6

Application

Say this psalm aloud as a prayer of thanks. Name three specific things for which you are thankful.

Remember that you were made by God and belong to him. Let that settle your restlessness.

Invite someone to church or to a conversation about Christ this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Enter God's gates with thanksgiving, naming specific things you are thankful for.

Thank him that you are the sheep of his pasture.

Praise him that his faithfulness reaches to every generation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 24

"Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture."

PSALM 100:3

DAY 168 · WEEK 24

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 100:3 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture."

PSALM 100:3

REST

Meditation

After a week of reading about rebellion, judgment, and the long wandering of the wilderness generation, Psalm 100:3 is a place to rest. It tells you who God is, and who you are.

"Know that the LORD, he is God." The verse begins with an instruction to know. Knowledge here is more than information. It is acknowledgment, the settled recognition of who is God and who is not. Much of Israel's trouble in the wilderness came from forgetting this.

"It is he who made us, and we are his." Two ideas come together: creation and belonging. God made us, so we depend on him for life. And we are his, so we are cared for. We do not have to prove ourselves or earn a place. Our identity rests on his making and his claim.

"We are his people." The phrase comes from the covenant: "I will take you to be my people, and I will be your God" (Exodus 6:7). It is a corporate identity, not only a private one. We belong to a people.

“And the sheep of his pasture.” Sheep are helpless and prone to wander. A shepherd leads them to food and water, protects them from wolves, and finds them when they are lost. The image describes how God treated Israel in the wilderness, even when they did not deserve it.

For the Christian, the verse finds its full meaning in Jesus, the good shepherd who lays down his life for the sheep (John 10:11). He knows his own and calls them by name, and no one can snatch them out of his hand (John 10:28).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed Israel through more of the wilderness. You read the laws that look ahead to the land, and the rebellion of Korah, which was answered by the earth opening and by Aaron standing between the living and the dead. You saw Aaron’s staff bud, learned that the priests have God himself as their inheritance, and read the puzzling law of the red heifer. You read of Moses’ failure at the rock, the death of Miriam and Aaron, and the bronze serpent that healed all who looked. You heard the story of Balaam, the prophet who could only bless, and the prophecy of the star out of Jacob. In the Psalms, you read Psalm 99, which holds God’s forgiveness and holiness together, and Psalm 100, a song of thanks. The week taught that God preserves his plan despite human failure, and that his chosen mediator saves.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Aaron stood between the living and the dead with a censer of incense, and the plague stopped. How does this picture help you understand what Jesus does for you?

The people were healed by looking at the bronze serpent. What does this story teach you about how faith works, and what do you need to look at today?

Psalm 100 says, “It is he who made us, and we are his.” How would it change your week to remember that you belong to God?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he made you and that you are his.

Thank Jesus, the good shepherd who lays down his life.

Rest in him today.

DAY 169 · WEEK 25

Numbers 25:1-27:23

Baal of Peor; Phinehas; the second census; Joshua commissioned

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 77 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 25:1-27:23. This reading includes a terrible sin at Baal of Peor, the zeal of Phinehas, a new census, the daughters of Zelophehad, and the commissioning of Joshua. Notice the way the story turns from failure to a new beginning.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel is still on the plains of Moab. After Balaam's oracles, you might expect everything to be well, but chapter 25 tells how the people joined in the worship of Baal of Peor and with Moabite women. A plague breaks out. Chapter 26 then begins a new census of the next generation, which is a way of marking that the old generation has gone. Chapter 27 deals with the inheritance rights of women and the appointment of Moses' successor.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "While Israel lived in Shittim, the people began to whore with the daughters of Moab" (25:1).
2. They join in the worship of Baal of Peor, and the LORD's anger is kindled (25:2-3).
3. Phinehas, the son of Eleazar, takes a spear and kills an Israelite man and a Midianite woman (25:6-8).
4. The plague stops, with 24,000 dead, and God makes a covenant of peace with Phinehas and his descendants (25:9-13).
5. A new census is taken, and "among these there was not one of those listed by Moses and Aaron… except Caleb… and Joshua" (26:64-65).

6. The five daughters of Zelophehad ask for their father's inheritance, since he had no sons (27:1-4).
7. God says, "The daughters of Zelophehad are right" and makes a law for the inheritance of daughters (27:5-11).
8. Moses asks God to appoint a leader, and God says, "Take Joshua the son of Nun, a man in whom is the Spirit" (27:15-23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sin of Baal of Peor shows how Israel's most dangerous enemy is not the army of a neighboring king but the attraction of other gods. Balaam, who could not curse Israel, found another way: he advised Balak to send women to seduce the Israelite men into idolatry (31:16). What a hired curse could not do, temptation did. The people fall into sexual immorality and the worship of a false god, the two sins that regularly appear together in the Bible. The plague that follows shows the seriousness of the offense.

Phinehas' action is hard to read. His zeal for God's honor stops the plague, and God commends him. But it is a violent act, in a setting where the nation was under the covenant penalties of the theocracy. It is not a model for private revenge. It shows the principle that when the community is polluted by sin, someone must stand in the gap. The promise of a "covenant of peace" to Phinehas is a reminder that even in judgment, God works through faithful servants.

The new census marks the end of the old generation. "Not one" was left except Caleb and Joshua. It is a quiet but powerful way of confirming God's word: what he said at Kadesh has come true. The people who feared the giants are gone, and their children are numbered. God keeps his word, both in judgment and in promise.

The story of the daughters of Zelophehad is a bright spot. The five sisters speak up in faith, believing that the land will be given and wanting a share in it. They come forward at a time when the old generation has just been shown to have lost its vision. Moses brings their case to God, and God says, "They are right." The inheritance laws are changed to include them. It is a case of faith being rewarded and the justice of God extending to those who might be overlooked.

The chapter ends with the commissioning of Joshua. Moses will not lead Israel into the land, and so a successor is appointed. He is a man "in whom is the Spirit," and he is publicly ordained with the laying on of hands.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul warns the Corinthians about the sin at Peor (1 Corinthians 10:8). Revelation 2:14 refers to the teaching of Balaam. Psalm 106:30-31 says that Phinehas' action was "counted to him as righteousness." Jesus, whose name is the Greek form of Joshua's, is the greater leader who brings his people into the true rest (Hebrews 4:8-9). The daughters of Zelophehad point forward to the truth that in Christ, there is "neither male nor female" in the inheritance (Galatians 3:28-29).

STEP 6

Application

Think about where you are most vulnerable to temptation, and take a concrete step to guard it.

Take heart from the daughters of Zelophehad. Ask God for something in faith, believing that he will keep his promises.

Pray for the next generation of leaders in your church, that they would be filled with the Spirit.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to guard your heart against rival loves.
- Thank him for keeping his word across generations.
- Pray for leaders filled with his Spirit.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 25

"And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place."

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

DAY 170 · WEEK 25

Numbers 28:1-30:16

The appointed offerings; the feasts; vows

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 28:1-30:16. These chapters give a calendar of offerings and the laws of vows. They may seem repetitive after the earlier readings in Leviticus, so read them with this question: why would God repeat this to a new generation?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first generation has died, and a new generation stands on the edge of the land. Moses restates the regular offerings and festivals to them. The daily offering, the Sabbath, the monthly new moon, and the annual feasts are all laid out, with their required sacrifices. Chapter 30 then deals with vows: who can make them, and who can annul them. The point is to prepare the people for life in the land, where worship will be part of daily rhythm.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Command the people of Israel and say to them, My food offering, my pleasing aroma, you shall be careful to offer to me at its appointed time" (28:2).
2. The daily offering is two lambs, one in the morning and one at twilight (28:3-8).
3. The Sabbath offering doubles the daily offering (28:9-10).
4. A monthly offering is made at the new moon (28:11-15).
5. Passover and Unleavened Bread are in the first month (28:16-25), the Feast of Weeks follows (28:26-31).
6. The seventh month has the Feast of Trumpets, the Day of Atonement, and the Feast of Booths (29:1-40).

7. “If a man vows a vow to the LORD, or swears an oath to bind himself by a pledge, he shall not break his word. He shall do according to all that proceeds out of his mouth” (30:2).

8. A father or husband may annul the vow of a daughter or wife under certain conditions (30:3-16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The repeated calendar of offerings is for a new generation. The people who stood at Sinai are gone, and their children need to hear the law again. It is a lesson in how faith is passed on. Every generation must be taught. The things God has commanded do not become unimportant because they were said once.

The daily offering is the foundation of the schedule. Every morning and every evening, a lamb was offered. Everything else, the Sabbath, the new moons, the feasts, was added on top of this daily rhythm. The sense is that the whole of life is lived under the sign of sacrifice. At the beginning and end of each day, God is acknowledged and sin is covered.

The calendar also builds toward the seventh month. The feasts cluster there, the Trumpets, the Day of Atonement, and Booths. The seventh month is the climax of the year, and it moves from the trumpet of awakening, through the cleansing of atonement, to the joy of the harvest. It is a movement that the church has always seen as a picture of the whole story of salvation.

The laws about vows come next. The principle in 30:2 is clear: a person must keep his word. Because a vow is made to the LORD, it is not something to be taken lightly. This is a hard word in an age when promises are cheap. The details about fathers and husbands annulling vows reflect the family structure of ancient Israel, and they show that vows were taken seriously enough to need regulation.

Behind all of it is the idea that worship is meant to be ordered. God does not leave it to our moods. He gives times, and he calls us to be faithful to them. This is not legalism. It is the discipline that keeps love alive.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the Lamb who was slain once for all, ending the need for daily sacrifices (Hebrews 10:11-14). Paul tells believers to “present your bodies as a living sacrifice” (Romans 12:1), and Hebrews 13:15 calls for a continual sacrifice of praise. Jesus taught, “Let what you say be

simply Yes or No" (Matthew 5:37), echoing the importance of keeping one's word. Colossians 2:17 says that the festivals are "a shadow of the things to come."

STEP 6

Application

Consider the daily rhythm of your own life. Do you begin and end the day with God?

Think about any promise you have made and not kept. Bring it to God and make it right.

Thank God that the daily sacrifice has been fulfilled in Christ, and offer him your praise today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he is worthy of worship at every time.
- Ask him to make you faithful to your word and to time with him.
- Thank Jesus, the Lamb who took away your sin once for all.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 25

"And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place."

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

DAY 171 · WEEK 25

Numbers 31:1-32:42

War with Midian; Reuben and Gad settle east of the Jordan

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 31:1-32:42. These chapters describe the war against Midian and the request of two and a half tribes to settle east of the Jordan. The first is difficult material. Read it with care and with the context of the whole book in mind.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

God had told Moses that after the matter of Peor, he would take vengeance on the Midianites, and then he would be gathered to his people. Chapter 31 describes the campaign. Chapter 32 then turns to the tribes of Reuben and Gad, and half of Manasseh, who have large herds and see that the land east of the Jordan is good for livestock. They ask to settle there. Moses is alarmed, because it sounds like the sin of the spies all over again.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God tells Moses, “Avenge the people of Israel on the Midianites. Afterward you shall be gathered to your people” (31:2).
2. Twelve thousand men, a thousand from each tribe, go out with Phinehas and the holy vessels (31:3-6).
3. They kill every male, including the five kings and Balaam son of Beor (31:7-8).
4. Moses is angry that the women who caused Israel to sin at Peor were spared (31:14-16).
5. The soldiers and anything that touched death must be purified (31:19-24).
6. The plunder is divided between the soldiers and the congregation, with a tribute to the LORD and to the Levites (31:25-47).
7. The tribes of Reuben and Gad ask to settle east of the Jordan (32:1-5).

8. Moses says, “Shall your brothers go to the war while you sit here?” and then agrees on the condition that they fight with the others until the land is taken (32:6-33). He warns, “Be sure your sin will find you out” (32:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The war with Midian is one of the more troubling stories in Scripture, and it deserves to be read honestly. It is presented as a judgment on a people who had deliberately tried to destroy Israel’s faith, and it is carried out as a holy war under God’s explicit command, under the leadership of the priest, and with the sacred vessels. It was not a general permission for violence. It was a specific judgment, in a specific time, on a specific people who had led Israel into idolatry.

Notice the attention to purity. The soldiers must be cleansed after the battle, and the plunder is purified. The text is clear that war is a defiling thing, even when commanded. The gold given to the LORD, 16,750 shekels, is accompanied by the confession that none of the men has been lost. These are the marks of a people who understand that they are not simply conquerors but servants.

The story of the eastern tribes is an important lesson about community responsibility. Reuben and Gad do not want to cross over. Moses’ first response is sharp, because he sees in it the same fear that destroyed their fathers. But the tribes explain that they will go before their brothers, armed, until the whole land is settled. Moses accepts, and he warns them that their word is binding before the LORD.

The sentence, “Be sure your sin will find you out,” is a proverb of its own. It is about the certainty that hidden or neglected obligations eventually come to light. Obligation to the community, kept or broken, is a matter of faithfulness to God.

The shape of the chapters is a warning against comfort. The tribes had found a good place and were tempted to stop short of the promise. We, too, can settle for good things this side of the Jordan. The call is to join our brothers in the greater work until it is done.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 4:11 says, “Let us therefore strive to enter that rest.” Paul tells believers to carry each other’s burdens (Galatians 6:2) and compares the church to a body (1 Corinthians 12). The warning to the eastern tribes echoes Jesus’ words about those who put their hand to the plow and look back (Luke 9:62). The war of Midian points to the ultimate battle against evil, which Christ has won (Colossians 2:15).

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you have settled for something good that is short of God's best for you.

Think about your obligations to your community. Are you carrying your share?

Consider the seriousness of sin. "Be sure your sin will find you out." Confess anything hidden.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from settling short of his best.
- Pray for those you walk beside, that you would be faithful to them.
- Thank Christ for winning the final victory over evil.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 25

"And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place."

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

DAY 172 · WEEK 25

Numbers 33:1-34:29

Stages of the journey; boundaries of the land

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 33:1-34:29. The first chapter is a travel diary of the entire journey from Egypt. The second sets out the boundaries of the land. Read the first as a testimony to God's faithfulness, and the second as a promise coming close.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel is about to cross the Jordan. Before they do, Moses records every stage of the journey from Egypt to the plains of Moab. There are forty-two stops. The record is written "by command of the LORD." Then God defines the borders of the land, names the leaders who will divide it, and gives instructions for the conquest.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Moses wrote down their starting places, stage by stage, by command of the LORD" (33:2).
2. The list begins with Rameses and ends with the plains of Moab by the Jordan (33:3-49).
3. Some of the stops are well known: the sea, Marah, Elim, Rephidim, Sinai, Kibroth-hattaavah, Kadesh (33:8-37).
4. Aaron died on Mount Hor at the age of 123 (33:38-39).
5. "When you pass over the Jordan into the land of Canaan, then you shall drive out all the inhabitants of the land from before you" (33:51-52).
6. Failure to drive them out will make them "as barbs in your eyes and thorns in your sides" (33:55).
7. The borders of the land are described on the south, west, north, and east (34:1-12).

8 Eleazar and Joshua, with one leader from each tribe, will divide the land (34:16-29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

A list of travel stops is not what we would choose to read for inspiration, but it says something important. Forty-two stages. Each name is a place where God's people camped, and where something happened. Some were places of failure, some of provision, and some of grief. The list shows that the whole journey, even the part that felt like wasted time, was part of God's plan. "By command of the LORD," Moses wrote it down.

The record is also a way of remembering. In the Psalms, the people are repeatedly told to recall the journey. This list gives a map for memory. If we want to understand God's faithfulness, we need to look back over the stages of our own lives and see how he led us. Few of us remember every stage. But God does.

The shift to the land of Canaan marks the end of the wilderness. For the first time since leaving Egypt, the people are given a goal with edges. The borders are described in detail, because the land is a gift with specific limits. It is real, and it is theirs.

The warning in 33:55 is sobering. If they do not drive out the inhabitants, those left will become "barbs in your eyes and thorns in your sides." The danger was not military but spiritual. Peoples who worshiped other gods would be a constant temptation. The book of Judges will show how it came true.

The assignment of leaders to divide the land is a final note of order. Eleazar the priest and Joshua the leader will work with one chief from each tribe. The land is not seized by individuals but received by the community, under the guidance of God's chosen leaders.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 11:13-16 describes the patriarchs as people who "confessed that they were strangers and exiles on the earth" and who longed for a heavenly country. Paul says that "all things work together for good for those who love God" (Romans 8:28), including the wanderings. Peter describes believers as "sojourners and exiles" (1 Peter 2:11). The new Jerusalem has boundaries too, and its dimensions are given in Revelation 21:15-17.

STEP 6

Application

Take a few minutes to list the stages of your own journey with God. Where have you seen his faithfulness?

Ask whether there is a “thorn in your side,” something you have left unresolved. Take a step to deal with it.

Thank God that your journey has a destination, and that he is leading you there.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for leading you stage by stage, remembering a step you can name.

Ask him to help you deal with the “thorns” you have left behind.

Look forward with him to the land he has promised.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 25

“And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place.”

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

DAY 173 · WEEK 25

Numbers 35:1-36:13

Levitical cities, cities of refuge; inheritance laws

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Numbers 35:1-36:13. The book ends with cities for the Levites, cities of refuge for those who kill accidentally, and a final ruling about inheritance. Read the cities of refuge slowly, as they are rich in meaning.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The tribes are about to receive their land. The Levites, who have no tribal territory, are to be given forty-eight cities scattered among the others. Six of these are designated as cities of refuge, places where a person who has killed someone accidentally can flee and be safe. The book concludes with a follow-up to the case of the daughters of Zelophehad, since the tribes were concerned that their inheritance might pass from tribe to tribe.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The Levites receive forty-eight cities with pasturelands (35:1-8).
2. Six are cities of refuge: three east of the Jordan, three west (35:9-15).
3. The one who kills by accident may flee to a city of refuge and be safe from “the avenger of blood” (35:11-12).
4. A murderer, however, may not take refuge, and must be put to death on the testimony of two or more witnesses (35:16-34).
5. The manslayer must stay in the city of refuge “until the death of the high priest” (35:25, 28).
6. “You shall not pollute the land in which you live, for blood pollutes the land, and no atonement can be made for the land for the blood that is shed in it, except by the blood

of the one who shed it" (35:33).

7. "You shall not defile the land in which you live, in the midst of which I dwell, for I the LORD dwell in the midst of the people of Israel" (35:34).

8. The tribes are to keep their inheritance, and women who inherit must marry within their tribe (36:1-12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The cities of refuge are one of the most beautiful provisions in the law. In the ancient world, if someone was killed, a relative was expected to take revenge. This cycle could consume whole families. God provides an alternative: places where a person who killed by accident could run and be safe until a fair trial. The law distinguishes between murder and manslaughter, and it protects the innocent while still taking life seriously.

The cities were spread out so that no one would be too far from one. The roads to them were kept in good repair, according to later tradition. They were open to everyone, Israelite or foreigner. The point is accessibility. A person in flight, with an avenger at his heels, could reach safety without delay.

The detail about the high priest is surprising. The manslayer must stay in the city until the high priest dies, and then he may go home. It seems arbitrary at first, but it contains a profound idea. The death of the high priest atones. His death is the end of the exile. It makes a way home for those who were under restraint.

The reason for the law is given in the last verses of chapter 35. Bloodshed pollutes the land, and the land cannot be cleansed except by the shedding of the murderer's blood. God dwells in the land, so its purity is a matter of life and death. The same principle runs through the whole of Leviticus: where God dwells, sin must be dealt with.

The final chapter returns to a practical matter and ends on a note of order and obedience. The daughters of Zelophehad do as they were told. The book that began with a census ends with an inheritance. After forty years, the people are ready, at least in terms of structure, to enter the land.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 6:18 speaks of those "who have fled for refuge" to lay hold of the hope set before them, and Jesus is the one in whom we find refuge. He is also the high priest whose death sets the captives free (Hebrews 9:15). Paul says, "There is therefore now no condemnation for

those who are in Christ Jesus" (Romans 8:1). Jesus prayed on the cross, "Father, forgive them, for they know not what they do" (Luke 23:34).

STEP 6

Application

Think of Christ as your city of refuge, and run to him with whatever guilt you carry.

Consider whether you hold a grudge against someone, and whether you could extend mercy.

Thank God that the death of the great high priest has opened the way home.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Flee to Christ as your refuge, and tell him what you are running from.

Ask him to keep you from the cycle of vengeance.

Ask him to make you quick to show mercy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 25

"And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place."

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

DAY 174 · WEEK 25

Deuteronomy 1:1-3:29

Moses recounts the journey, covenant history

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 1:1-3:29. A new book begins, and it is a series of sermons by Moses. Notice how he looks backward to the journey from Sinai, and what he says to the new generation about what their parents did.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Deuteronomy means "second law." It takes place on the plains of Moab, in the last weeks of Moses' life. Forty years have passed since the exodus. A new generation, most of whom were children or unborn at Sinai, stands ready to cross the Jordan. Moses preaches to them in a series of speeches. The first section, which you read today, is a historical review: it recalls how God led Israel from Horeb to this place, and why they are here and not in the land already.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It is eleven days" journey from Horeb by the way of Mount Seir to Kadesh-barnea' (1:2).
2. "The LORD our God said to us in Horeb, You have stayed long enough at this mountain" (1:6).
3. Moses recounts how he appointed leaders to share the burden of judging (1:9-18).
4. The people refused to enter the land: "Because the LORD hated us he has brought us out of the land of Egypt" (1:27).
5. "The LORD your God... carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went" (1:31).

6. Because of their unbelief, the LORD swore that none of that generation would see the land, except Caleb (1:34-36).
7. Moses was also barred from entering because of the people (1:37; 3:23-27).
8. God gives victories over Sihon and Og, and Moses sees the land from Mount Pisgah (2:26-3:29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Moses begins by looking back, and what he says is a lesson in the right use of memory. He remembers the failures honestly, including his own burden and the people's refusal. But he also remembers God's care. The most beautiful line is 1:31: "in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son." Behind the story of rebellion and judgment, there was a father carrying his child.

The review has a purpose. The new generation needs to understand why they are standing east of the Jordan, and why the land is a gift and not an achievement. If they think the land is theirs by right, they will repeat their fathers' mistake. Moses tells the story so that they will learn to trust.

It also reveals the heart of the old generation's sin. They said, "Because the LORD hated us he has brought us out of Egypt." This is a shocking accusation. The very act of rescue became evidence of hatred in their minds. It is a picture of what unbelief does. It takes God's love and turns it inside out.

Moses' mention of his own exclusion from the land shows an honesty in leadership. He does not hide his failure or pretend that it was unjust. He says that God was angry with him "on your account," and that he pleaded for mercy and was refused. The leader shares the consequences of the people's sin, and in that sense he points beyond himself to one who would bear them fully.

The chapters end with Moses on the mountain, looking over the land he will not enter, and with the command to charge and encourage Joshua. The torch is passed. The people will go in, and Moses will not. But God will be with Joshua.

STEP 5

Connection

Stephen's speech in Acts 7 retells this history, and Paul preaches a similar summary in Acts 13:18, citing Deuteronomy 1:31: "he put up with them in the wilderness." Isaiah 63:9 says, "In all their affliction he was afflicted… he lifted them up and carried them all the days of old."

Jesus said, “Come to me… and I will give you rest” (Matthew 11:28). Moses looks at the land from afar, as Hebrews 11:13 says of all the faithful.

STEP 6

Application

Take time to remember how God has carried you. Write down two or three instances.

Ask whether you have ever interpreted God’s care as hostility, and tell him about it.

Think about those you are leading or teaching. How might you pass on what God has done?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for carrying you as a father carries his son, naming a time you did not know it.

Confess where you mistook his love for hatred.

Ask him to teach you to remember his works and pass them on.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 25

“And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place.”

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

DAY 175 · WEEK 25

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Deuteronomy 1:31 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place."

DEUTERONOMY 1:31

REST

Meditation

Deuteronomy 1:31 is a single sentence, spoken at the end of a forty-year journey, that changes how we look at the whole wilderness.

"In the wilderness." The wilderness is the place of testing and failure in the Bible. It is where Israel grumbled, rebelled, and wandered. Moses does not deny any of it. But he tells them to look again.

"Where you saw how the LORD your God carried you." The people had seen many things in the wilderness: manna, water from the rock, fire and cloud. Moses asks them to see the hidden side of the story. In all their complaining and unbelief, someone had been carrying them.

“As a man carries his son.” It is a tender picture of a father carrying a child too small or too tired to walk. It is not the image of a general leading an army. It is the image of a parent who picks up a child, who does not shame them for being weak, and who brings them all the way home.

“All the way that you went until you came to this place.” The carrying was not occasional but constant. Every step of the forty years was a step taken with God’s help. The place where they stood was the result of his faithfulness and not their strength.

For the Christian, the verse is an assurance. “He who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ” (Philippians 1:6). The Father who carried Israel carries his children still, through the Son who bore our sins.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you came to the end of the book of Numbers and the beginning of Deuteronomy. You read about the sin at Baal of Peor and the zeal of Phinehas, the new census that confirmed God’s word about the old generation, and the daughters of Zelophehad, who asked for an inheritance by faith. You read of Joshua’s commissioning, the calendar of offerings, the war against Midian, and the request of the eastern tribes. You read the travel record of the forty-two stages and the boundaries of the land. You learned of the cities of refuge and the death of the high priest that sets the manslayer free. Then Moses began his sermons on the plains of Moab, looking back over the journey and reminding the new generation that God had carried them. The week taught that God keeps his word in judgment and in promise, and that he is the one who carries his people.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Moses says that God carried Israel “as a man carries his son.” Where have you seen God carry you in a time you were not aware of it, and what would it mean to thank him for it?

The manslayer was freed by the death of the high priest. How does this picture deepen your understanding of what Christ’s death accomplished?

Moses recalled the past honestly, including his own failure. What do you need to remember honestly about your own journey, and how might that help you trust God for the future?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for carrying you when you did not know it.

Ask him to help you remember his faithfulness.

Rest in him, trusting him for the road ahead.

DAY 176 · WEEK 26

Psalm 78:1-39

Teaching the next generation, remembering God's works

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 39 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 78:1-39. This is a long psalm that retells Israel's history as a lesson for the next generation. Today's section covers the exodus and the wilderness. Read it alongside what you have just finished in Numbers.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 78 is a psalm of Asaph, and it is the second longest psalm in the Psalter. It is called a "maskil," a teaching psalm. Its purpose is stated in the first verses: to tell the coming generation the glorious deeds of the LORD, so that they might set their hope in God and not be like their fathers, a stubborn and rebellious generation. Today's reading, verses 1 to 39, retells the events of Exodus and Numbers with a focus on Israel's repeated forgetfulness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give ear, O my people, to my teaching; incline your ears to the words of my mouth!" (v. 1).
2. "We will not hide them from their children, but tell to the coming generation the glorious deeds of the LORD" (v. 4).
3. The purpose: "that they should set their hope in God and not forget the works of God, but keep his commandments" (v. 7).
4. "The Ephraimites, armed with the bow, turned back on the day of battle" (v. 9).
5. "They forgot what he had done and the wonders that he had shown them" (v. 11).
6. "He divided the sea and let them pass through it, and made the waters stand like a heap" (v. 13).

7. “Yet they sinned still more against him, rebelling against the Most High in the desert” (v. 17).

8. “But he, being compassionate, atoned for their iniquity and did not destroy them; he restrained his anger often and did not stir up all his wrath. He remembered that they were but flesh, a wind that passes and comes not again” (vv. 38-39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm has a clear structure. It begins with the duty to teach the next generation. Then it gives the story, a long alternating pattern of God’s miracles and Israel’s rebellion. Five times in this section alone, the pattern repeats: God acts, the people forget, and God responds with both discipline and mercy. The psalm reads like a summary of Numbers.

The reason for telling the story is that memory is the cure for unbelief. The people turned back in battle, not because the enemy was strong, but because “they forgot what he had done.” When we forget God’s past faithfulness, we cannot trust his present promises. That is why Moses’ whole book of Deuteronomy is built around the word “remember.”

Look at the pattern in verses 17 to 22. The people ask for food, and they test God, saying, “Can God spread a table in the wilderness?” The question is not wrong in itself. It is that they ask it in unbelief, after seeing him divide the sea and bring water from the rock. They want to see if God can do one more thing. It is a picture of the way we treat God when we hold his past gifts at arm’s length.

The center of the section is verses 38 and 39: “He, being compassionate, atoned for their iniquity and did not destroy them.” The key word is “atoned.” God’s compassion is not just a feeling. It leads to action. He provides a covering for sin. And his reason is gentle: “He remembered that they were but flesh.” God knows our frailty. He does not forget it.

The psalm ends today’s section with a mixture of warning and comfort. We can be as stubborn as Israel, but God is more patient than we are stubborn. That is the hope we carry as we teach our children the story.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that the events of the wilderness “took place as examples for us” (1 Corinthians 10:6), and in Romans 15:4 that “whatever was written in former days was written for our instruction.” Jesus quoted this psalm’s words about manna when he said that he is the true

bread from heaven (John 6:31). Psalm 103:14 echoes verses 38 and 39: “he knows our frame; he remembers that we are dust.” Hebrews 2:17 says that Christ is a merciful high priest who made propitiation for our sins.

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of the works of God that you want to remember, and share one with a child or younger believer this week.

Ask whether there is an area where you are testing God, doubting that he can provide.

Thank God that he remembers you are dust, and that his compassion made atonement.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you tell the next generation of his glorious deeds.

Confess where you forget what he has done.

Thank him for compassion that remembers you are dust.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 26

“And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise.”

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

DAY 177 · WEEK 26

Deuteronomy 4:1-5:33

Obey the law; the Ten Commandments repeated

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 4:1-5:33. Moses turns from history to instruction. He urges Israel to obey, and he restates the Ten Commandments. Notice the reasons he gives for obedience.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Having reviewed the journey, Moses begins his second major address. The word "now" in 4:1 marks the turn: "And now, O Israel, listen to the statutes and the rules that I am teaching you." He wants the people to keep the law carefully, because it is their wisdom before the nations. Then, in chapter 5, he gathers the whole assembly and repeats the Ten Commandments given at Horeb, with some variations from the version in Exodus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You shall not add to the word that I command you, nor take from it" (4:2).
2. "Keep them and do them, for that will be your wisdom and your understanding in the sight of the peoples" (4:6).
3. "For what great nation is there that has a god so near to it as the LORD our God is to us, whenever we call upon him?" (4:7).
4. "You saw no form on the day that the LORD spoke to you at Horeb out of the midst of the fire" (4:15).
5. "The LORD your God is a merciful God. He will not leave you or destroy you or forget the covenant with your fathers" (4:31).
6. "Hear, O Israel, the statutes and the rules that I speak in your hearing today" (5:1).

7. The Ten Commandments are given again (5:6-21), with the Sabbath commandment grounded in the exodus: “You shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt” (5:15).

8. The people say, “Go near and hear all that the LORD our God will say… and we will hear and do it” (5:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Moses begins with a startling claim: the law is a gift that makes Israel the envy of the nations. The nations will hear these statutes and say, “Surely this great nation is a wise and understanding people.” Obedience is not a burden but a witness. The law shows what a people ruled by a just and loving God would look like.

The reason is not just the laws, but the God who gave them. “What great nation has a god so near to it?” The nearness of God is the glory of Israel. The other nations had gods to be placated from afar. Israel’s God spoke from the fire and called them to himself.

Moses warns against making images. At Horeb, the people heard a voice, but they saw no form. That was deliberate. A God who cannot be pictured cannot be controlled. Moses stresses that the temptation to make an image, to shape God into something we can handle, is real, and he warns of the consequences.

The restatement of the Ten Commandments in chapter 5 shows how the law was meant to be internalized. The same words that were spoken to the previous generation are now spoken to the next, in the present tense: “The LORD made this covenant not with our fathers but with us, who are all of us here alive today” (5:3). Each generation must receive the covenant as its own.

One difference from Exodus is that the Sabbath commandment gives a new reason. In Exodus, it is based on creation. Here, it is based on redemption: “You shall remember that you were a slave.” The Sabbath is a gift to those who were once denied rest, and it extends rest to servants and animals.

The people’s response sounds right. “We will hear and do it.” But God says that he wishes they had such a heart always. Hearing and doing are the key, and the whole book will keep returning to them.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Think not that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them” (Matthew 5:17). He is the visible image of the invisible God (Colossians 1:15), the “form” that Israel did not see. Paul says that the law was a guardian until Christ came (Galatians 3:24). Jesus says, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments” (John 14:15).

STEP 6

Application

Read the Ten Commandments aloud slowly. Ask which one the Spirit is pressing on you this week.

Think about how your life displays the wisdom of God to those around you.

Thank God that he is near, and that you can call upon him at any time.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he has drawn near in Jesus.

Ask him to write his commandments on your heart.

Ask him to let your obedience be a witness to those around you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 26

“And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise.”

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

DAY 178 · WEEK 26

Deuteronomy 6:1-8:20

The Shema; love and memory; do not forget God

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 77 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 6:1-8:20. This is the heart of the book. It contains the Shema, the greatest commandment, and Moses' warnings about forgetting God in prosperity. Read chapter 6 slowly, and think about verses 4 to 9 as the center.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses now moves from the Ten Commandments to their meaning. These chapters begin with the greatest commandment and then apply it to life in the land. They deal with passing faith to the next generation, the dangers of prosperity, and the testing in the wilderness. The Shema, the opening words of 6:4, are recited by Jewish people daily to this day.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one" (6:4).
2. "You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might" (6:5).
3. "And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart" (6:6).
4. "You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise" (6:7).
5. "When your son asks you in time to come, What is the meaning of the testimonies… then you shall say to your son, We were Pharaoh's slaves in Egypt" (6:20-21).
6. The LORD did not set his love on Israel because they were more in number, but "because the LORD loves you and is keeping the oath that he swore to your fathers" (7:7-

8).

7. “And you shall remember the whole way that the LORD your God has led you these forty years in the wilderness, that he might humble you, testing you” (8:2).

8. “Man does not live by bread alone, but man lives by every word that comes from the mouth of the LORD” (8:3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Shema is the center of Israel’s faith, and of the Bible’s teaching about God. “The LORD our God, the LORD is one.” There is one God, and he is the covenant God. The statement is both theological and personal. He is “our God.” And the response to him is not just assent but love, with the whole person: heart, soul, and might.

Moses ties love to obedience, and obedience to teaching. The words are to be on the heart first, before they are taught to the children. A parent cannot pass on what he does not hold. And the teaching is to happen in all of ordinary life: at home, on the road, at bedtime, at waking. It is not a classroom subject. It is the atmosphere of the household. The signs on the hand and forehead and doorposts are reminders that faith belongs to every part of life.

Then comes a warning about success. “When the LORD your God brings you into the land… take care lest you forget the LORD.” The danger is not hardship but plenty. In good times, we easily imagine that we have earned what we have. Moses says, “You shall remember the LORD your God, for it is he who gives you power to get wealth” (8:18).

Chapter 7 gives a stunning reason for God’s choice of Israel. It was not their size or strength. “The LORD set his love on you” because he loved you. There is no explanation behind love except love itself. This is grace in the Old Testament.

The wilderness years, according to chapter 8, were not wasted. God humbled and tested them to teach one lesson: “Man does not live by bread alone.” Jesus quoted it when tempted in the desert. The manna was a lesson in daily dependence. The forty years were a school of trust.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus calls the Shema “the great and first commandment” (Matthew 22:36-38), and he quotes Deuteronomy 8:3 against Satan (Matthew 4:4). Paul says that “there is one God, the Father… and one Lord, Jesus Christ” (1 Corinthians 8:6), and John says that God’s love for us was shown when “he sent his Son” (1 John 4:10). Ephesians 6:4 tells fathers to bring up their children “in the discipline and instruction of the Lord.”

STEP 6

Application

Say the Shema aloud, slowly. Ask what it would mean to love God with every part of you.

Think of one concrete way you can bring God's word into the ordinary rhythms of your home this week.

Ask whether prosperity or comfort has dulled your dependence on God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to love him with all your heart, soul, and might, and where that is hard.

Ask him to keep you from forgetting him in good times.

Ask him to help you teach his words to someone else.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 26

"And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise."

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

DAY 179 · WEEK 26

Deuteronomy 9:1-11:32

Not by your righteousness; God's love for the patriarchs

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 85 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 9:1-11:32. Moses continues his warning about the danger of self-righteousness. He retells the story of the golden calf, and ends with a call to love and obey. Notice how often he says "not because of your righteousness."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel is about to cross the Jordan and to defeat nations stronger than themselves. Moses warns them not to think that this is because of their goodness. In fact, they have been "a stubborn people" from the day they left Egypt. He recalls the golden calf, Moses' intercession, and the second set of tablets. He closes with a call to fear and love the LORD, a promise of blessing, and the first mention of the blessing and curse to be pronounced at Gerizim and Ebal.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Know therefore that the LORD your God is not giving you this good land to possess because of your righteousness, for you are a stubborn people" (9:6).
2. "From the day you came out of the land of Egypt until you came to this place, you have been rebellious against the LORD" (9:7).
3. Moses recounts the forty days on the mountain and the golden calf, and how he fell down before the LORD for forty days and nights (9:9-29).
4. The LORD wrote the commandments again on two new tablets and put them in the ark (10:1-5).
5. "And now, Israel, what does the LORD your God require of you, but to fear the LORD your God, to walk in all his ways, to love him, to serve the LORD your God with all your

heart and with all your soul" (10:12).

6. "Circumcise therefore the foreskin of your heart, and be no longer stubborn" (10:16).
7. "He executes justice for the fatherless and the widow, and loves the sojourner, giving him food and clothing. Love the sojourner, therefore" (10:18-19).
8. "Behold, I am setting before you today a blessing and a curse" (11:26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The centerpiece of this section is the repeated phrase, "not because of your righteousness." Moses says it again and again. Israel's coming victory will not be a reward for their goodness. It will be an act of God's faithfulness to his promise and a judgment on the wickedness of the nations. The land is a gift, and it is an act of grace to a stubborn people.

The retelling of the golden calf is meant to humble. Moses recalls the very worst moment: that at the foot of the mountain where God had just spoken, the people turned to a calf. And he recalls his own intercession, forty days of prostration. Without it, God would have destroyed them. The point is not to shame, but to show that their standing before God depends on his mercy and on a mediator, and not on their record.

Then comes the great question of 10:12: "What does the LORD your God require of you?" The answer is a list, but it is all one thing: fear, walk, love, serve. The center is love. After a long section about rebellion, the call is not to a new set of rules, but to a heart. And God asks this because he has first loved them: "Yet the LORD set his heart in love on your fathers" (10:15).

The command to "circumcise your heart" in 10:16 is one of the most important phrases in the Old Testament. It shows that the real issue was never the outward mark, but the inner condition. Later, Deuteronomy 30:6 promises that God himself will do this, and Jeremiah and Ezekiel pick it up as the promise of the new covenant.

The portrait of God in 10:17-19 is striking. He is "God of gods and Lord of lords," great and awesome, who takes no bribe, and who loves the sojourner. The most powerful being in the universe is the protector of the powerless. Those who belong to him are to imitate that care.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says, "By grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works" (Ephesians 2:8-9). He writes that "circumcision is a matter of the heart, by the Spirit" (Romans 2:29). Jesus said that to love the LORD with all your heart is the great commandment, and that we are to love our neighbor, including the stranger. In Christ, God has given the new heart (Ezekiel 36:26).

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you are tempted to think that blessings come because you deserve them. Replace that thought with gratitude.

Pray 10:12 as a personal prayer. Which of the verbs, fear, walk, love, serve, do you most need this week?

Show practical love to a stranger or someone vulnerable.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his love for you is not based on your righteousness.

Ask him to circumcise your heart.

Ask him to teach you to fear, walk with, love, and serve him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 26

"And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise."

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

DAY 180 · WEEK 26

Psalm 78:40-72

God's patience with rebellion; David chosen as shepherd-king

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 33 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 78:40-72. This is the second half of the history psalm. It continues from the wilderness through the plagues of Egypt, the conquest, the failures in the land, and ends with the choice of David. Notice how the story ends.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 78 continues. Verses 40 to 72 go back over the exodus, with the plagues, and then move forward through the settlement in the land, Israel's idolatry, the capture of the ark, God's rejection of Shiloh, and his choice of Judah and David. It is a summary of the story from Exodus to 2 Samuel, and it ends with a hopeful note.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "How often they rebelled against him in the wilderness and grieved him in the desert!" (v. 40).
2. "They did not remember his power or the day when he redeemed them from the foe" (vv. 42-43).
3. The plagues of Egypt are named: blood, flies, frogs, locusts, hail, pestilence, and the death of the firstborn (vv. 44-51).
4. "Then he led out his people like sheep and guided them in the wilderness like a flock" (v. 52).
5. "Yet they tested and rebelled against the Most High God and did not keep his testimonies" (v. 56).

6. “They provoked him to anger with their high places; they moved him to jealousy with their idols” (v. 58).
7. “He forsook his dwelling at Shiloh, the tent where he dwelt among mankind, and delivered his power to captivity” (vv. 60-61).
8. “He chose David his servant and took him from the sheepfolds… to shepherd Jacob his people… With upright heart he shepherded them and guided them with his skillful hand” (vv. 70-72).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The second half of the psalm shows what happens in the land. The pattern from the wilderness continues. God brings them in, but they test him again and turn to idols. Judgment follows: the ark is captured and Shiloh falls. These are events from the period of Samuel that you will read about soon. The psalm sees all of it as a single pattern: grace, rebellion, judgment, and then, remarkably, grace again.

The surprise comes at the end. After a long account of failure, the psalm does not end with destruction. It ends with the choice of David. “He chose David his servant.” The LORD wakes up like a man who has been asleep and chooses a new shepherd for his people. The humble beginnings are important. David is taken “from the sheepfolds, from following the nursing ewes.” God’s way is to raise up the unlikely.

The picture of the king is a shepherd. “He shepherded them with upright heart and guided them with his skillful hand.” This is the model for leadership in Israel: a shepherd who cares for the flock. It is the same image that opens the wilderness section: “He led out his people like sheep.” The one who led Israel through the desert through Moses will now lead them through David.

For anyone who has read the whole story from Genesis to Deuteronomy, the psalm gives a long view. The failure is real, and God’s judgment is real, but his plan is not defeated. He is working toward the shepherd king, a descendant of David, who will lead his people perfectly.

The lesson for the next generation is that God’s faithfulness is the thread in the story. Our failures are not the point. His mercy is. That is what the children are to be taught.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the Son of David and the good shepherd (John 10:11). Matthew 9:36 says that when he saw the crowds, “he had compassion for them, because they were harassed and helpless, like sheep without a shepherd.” Ezekiel 34:23 promises that God will set one shepherd over them,

his servant David. In 1 Peter 5:4, Jesus is called the “chief Shepherd.” Hebrews 13:20 calls him “the great shepherd of the sheep.”

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on the pattern in your own story: grace, failure, discipline, and grace again. Thank God for his steadiness.

Think about who has shepherded you spiritually. Thank them, and pray for them.

Ask how you might shepherd those entrusted to you, with a pure heart and skillful hands.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus, the good shepherd who laid down his life.
- Ask God to help you tell the story of his faithfulness to those near you.
- Thank him for choosing and leading shepherds for his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 26

“And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise.”

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

DAY 181 · WEEK 26

Deuteronomy 12:1-14:29

Centralized worship; false prophets; clean and unclean foods

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 12:1-14:29. These chapters begin the long section of specific laws. They deal with worship in one place, warnings about false prophets, and rules about food and tithes. Read them with attention to why God gives each one.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

From chapter 12 to chapter 26, Moses applies the Ten Commandments to the life of Israel in the land. The first group of laws is about worship. Israel is to worship only in the place God chooses, to destroy the altars of the nations, and to resist the temptation to follow other gods, even when it comes from a prophet or a family member. Chapter 14 returns to the clean and unclean foods and the tithe.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You shall surely destroy all the places where the nations whom you shall dispossess served their gods" (12:2).
2. "You shall seek the place that the LORD your God will choose out of all your tribes... and there you shall go" (12:5).
3. "You shall rejoice before the LORD your God, you and your sons and your daughters" (12:12).
4. A prophet who tells Israel to follow other gods is to be rejected, "for the LORD your God is testing you" (13:1-3).
5. Even a brother, a son, or a close friend who entices to idolatry must not be heeded (13:6-11).

6. “You are the sons of the LORD your God” (14:1).
7. The clean and unclean animals are listed again (14:3-21), with the reason, “For you are a people holy to the LORD your God” (14:2, 21).
8. The tithe is to be eaten before the LORD with rejoicing, and every third year given to the Levite, the sojourner, the fatherless, and the widow (14:22-29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

These chapters are about protecting the purity of worship. The command to centralize worship at one place might seem merely administrative, but it has a theological purpose. Dozens of local altars would invite syncretism, mixing the worship of the LORD with the practices of Canaan. One place, chosen by God, keeps the worship unified and under his direction.

The repeated call to rejoice is easy to miss. Worship is to be a feast. The people are told to eat and rejoice in God’s presence, with their families, their servants, and the Levites. This is a faith of celebration. The tithe is not only a tax. It is a meal, a feast shared with the poor and the stranger. Every third year, the tithe is stored locally to care for the vulnerable.

Chapter 13 contains a hard word. Even a prophet who performs signs is to be rejected if he leads people to other gods. The test is not power but doctrine. And God says that such a prophet is a test, “to know whether you love the LORD your God with all your heart.” Love for God is shown by loyalty to his word, even when someone with an impressive sign says otherwise. This applies to those closest to us as well: love for God must not be overridden by family ties.

The beginning of chapter 14 gives the reason for the food laws: “You are the sons of the LORD your God.” They are not arbitrary rules. They are marks of identity. The distinctive diet was a daily reminder that Israel was God’s family.

These chapters show that holiness is expressed in how we worship, whom we follow, what we eat, and how we care for the poor. It is a whole life. And at its center is gladness, not grim duty.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told the woman at the well that “the hour is coming, and is now here, when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth” (John 4:23). The warning about false prophets is repeated by Jesus (Matthew 7:15) and by John (1 John 4:1). Peter was shown that

no food is unclean (Acts 10:15), and Paul said that the kingdom of God is "righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit" (Romans 14:17). Hebrews 12:22-24 describes the joyful assembly of the church.

STEP 6

Application

Think about whether your worship has joy in it. Plan one way to celebrate God's goodness with others this week.

Test the voices you listen to by Scripture. Ask whether any are leading you away from Christ.

Give generously, and include someone in need.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you from loving anything more than him.

Thank him that you are his son or daughter.

Ask him to make you generous to the poor.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 26

"And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise."

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

DAY 182 · WEEK 26

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Deuteronomy 6:6-7 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise."

DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

REST

Meditation

These two verses follow the Shema and describe how love for God is meant to be lived out. They are among the most practical verses in the Bible.

"These words that I command you today shall be on your heart." The order matters. Before anything is taught to anyone else, the words must be on your own heart. A parent, teacher, or leader cannot pass on what he does not possess. The heart is the starting point.

"You shall teach them diligently to your children." The word "diligently" means to sharpen, as one sharpens a blade. It suggests repetition and care. Faith is not passed on by accident. It requires intention and effort. Notice that the commandment is addressed to parents. God's design is for faith to be taught at home first.

“And shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise.” This is the surprising part. The teaching is not limited to a scheduled lesson. It is woven into the whole day: sitting, walking, going to bed, getting up. Every part of life becomes a moment to speak of God.

For the Christian, the verses call us to make Scripture and prayer part of our household. It is a ministry for parents, but also for grandparents, aunts, uncles, church members, and friends. In Christ, the whole community of believers shares the task of passing on the faith to the next generation.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the opening sermons of Deuteronomy. You saw how Moses looked back at the wilderness, how he restated the Ten Commandments, and how he gave the Shema, the greatest commandment. You read about God’s choice of Israel, not because of their righteousness, and about Moses’ intercession after the golden calf. You prayed through Psalm 78, which tells the whole story from the exodus to David as a lesson for the next generation. You read the first laws about worship, false prophets, clean foods, and the tithe. The week taught that obedience flows from love, that faith must be passed on at home, and that God’s grace is not based on our merit.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Shema says that God is one and calls for love with heart, soul, and might. Which of these three, heart, soul, or might, is the hardest for you to give, and why?

Moses told Israel three times that God’s gift was “not because of your righteousness.” How does Christ’s work on your behalf give you the same assurance?

Deuteronomy 6 says to teach faith “when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way.” What is one practical step you could take this week to talk about God in the course of ordinary life?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to put his words on your heart and help you teach them to those near you.

Thank him that his love is not based on your merit.

Rest in him today.

DAY 183 · WEEK 27

Deuteronomy 15:1-16:22

Sabbath year; the feasts of remembrance

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 15:1-16:22. These chapters deal with the release of debts, the care of the poor, the freeing of slaves, and the three great pilgrim feasts. Notice how generosity is rooted in remembering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses continues applying the law to life in the land. Chapter 15 describes the Sabbath year, in which debts are released every seventh year, and the freeing of Hebrew slaves. Chapter 16 sets out the three annual feasts: Passover, Weeks, and Booths. These laws shape a community in which no one is permanently poor and every family rejoices together.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "At the end of every seven years you shall grant a release" (15:1).
2. "But there will be no poor among you… if only you will strictly obey the voice of the LORD" (15:4-5).
3. "If among you, one of your brothers should become poor… you shall not harden your heart or shut your hand against your poor brother" (15:7).
4. "You shall open your hand to your brother, to the needy and to the poor, in your land" (15:11).
5. "For there will never cease to be poor in the land" (15:11).
6. Hebrew slaves are to be freed in the seventh year and sent out with gifts: "You shall not let him go empty-handed" (15:12-15).

7. “You shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt, and the LORD your God redeemed you” (15:15).

8. The three feasts are Passover, Weeks, and Booths, and “they shall not appear before the LORD empty-handed” (16:16-17). Judges are to “follow justice, and only justice” (16:18-20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The laws in chapter 15 are among the most radical in the Bible. Every seven years, debts are cancelled. The point is to prevent a permanent underclass. In most societies, debt becomes a trap that passes from generation to generation. God’s law builds in a periodic reset.

There is a tension in the passage that is worth noticing. Verse 4 says that there will be no poor among you if you obey. Verse 11 says that the poor will never cease from the land. Both are true. The first is the goal of the law, a society so generous that poverty cannot take root. The second is the realistic observation that because of sin, the ideal will not be fully reached. The command that follows is to open your hand anyway.

The sentence that gives the law its power is 15:15: “You shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt, and the LORD your God redeemed you.” Generosity is rooted in memory. The reason the Israelite should free a slave is that he was freed. The reason he gives is that he was given to. The gospel always works this way: we love because he first loved us.

The detail about sending a freed slave away with gifts shows the spirit of the law. He is not just released; he is given a start. “You shall furnish him liberally from your flock, your threshing floor, and your winepress.” Grace is not stingy.

Chapter 16 sets out the pilgrim feasts as occasions of joy. Everyone is to take part: sons, daughters, servants, Levites, strangers, orphans, and widows. And the instruction to judges to pursue justice, and only justice, completes the picture of a society in which God’s character is reflected.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus announced the “year of the LORD’s favor” (Luke 4:19) and taught, “Give to everyone who begs from you” (Luke 6:30). He said, “For you always have the poor with you” (Matthew 26:11), referring to Deuteronomy 15:11. Paul says, “You know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor” (2 Corinthians 8:9). The church in Acts shared its goods so that “there was not a needy person among them” (Acts 4:34).

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your hand is open or closed toward someone in need. Make a concrete gift this week.

Forgive a debt or a wrong that someone owes you.

Remember your own redemption, and let it shape how you treat others.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for redeeming you and being generous beyond measure.

Ask him to open your hand to someone in need.

Ask him to teach you to forgive as you have been forgiven.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 27

"The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen."

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

DAY 184 · WEEK 27

Deuteronomy 18:15-19; Psalm 110; Hebrews 1:1-4

The Three Offices of Christ, Prophet, Priest, King

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 18:15-19, Psalm 110, and Hebrews 1:1-4. Take your time with these three short passages. They each speak of one of the three offices that God established in Israel, prophet, priest, and king, and the way that all three come together in Jesus.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Today's reading pauses in the middle of the laws of Deuteronomy, just before the chapter that sets out the roles of kings, priests, and prophets in Israel (Deuteronomy 17 and 18). It pauses to ask a question that will come up many times in the story ahead: how do the offices of Israel point to Christ? The three passages you read today are central. Moses promises a prophet like himself, David writes of a king who is also a priest forever, and the writer of Hebrews says that in Jesus, God has spoken his final word.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen" (Deuteronomy 18:15).
2. "I will put my words in his mouth, and he shall speak to them all that I command him" (Deuteronomy 18:18).
3. "The LORD says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool" (Psalm 110:1).
4. "The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind: You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek" (Psalm 110:4).

5. “He will execute judgment among the nations, filling them with corpses” (Psalm 110:6).
6. “Long ago, at many times and in many ways, God spoke to our fathers by the prophets, but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son” (Hebrews 1:1-2).
7. “He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power” (Hebrews 1:3).
8. “After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high” (Hebrews 1:3).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The three offices of Christ is a way of organizing what the Bible teaches about who Jesus is and what he does. It was developed by John Calvin and has been used by Reformed and many other Christian traditions ever since. It rests on a simple observation: in the Old Testament, three kinds of people were anointed to serve God’s people, the prophet, the priest, and the king. Each represents a way in which God relates to his people. Each was incomplete. And all three find their fulfillment in the one called Messiah, which means “Anointed One.”

Consider the prophet first. A prophet speaks for God to the people. Moses was the model prophet, to whom God spoke “mouth to mouth” (Numbers 12:8). In Deuteronomy 18, Moses promises that God would one day raise up another like him. Over the centuries, many prophets came, but the people kept waiting for the prophet. Jesus is that prophet, and more. The Gospel of John says, “No one has ever seen God; the only God, who is at the Father’s side, he has made him known” (John 1:18). Where prophets spoke the word of God, Jesus is the Word of God. Hebrews 1 says that God has now spoken by his Son. As prophet, Christ reveals the Father to us and teaches us the truth. He does this through his own teaching, through the Spirit who inspired the Scriptures, and through the Spirit who illumines our hearts.

Consider the priest next. A priest speaks to God on behalf of the people. He offers sacrifices, makes intercession, and blesses. The priests of Israel, from Aaron onward, did this imperfectly. They were sinners, and they died, so that new priests were always needed. Psalm 110:4 announces a priest of another kind, “after the order of Melchizedek,” a priest forever. Hebrews develops this at length. Jesus is the great high priest who has offered, once for all, the perfect sacrifice, namely himself (Hebrews 7:27). He continually intercedes for us at the right hand of God (Romans 8:34; Hebrews 7:25). As priest, Christ reconciles us to God by his death and keeps us in fellowship with him by his prayers.

Consider the king last. A king rules the people on behalf of God. David was the model king, and God promised him a son who would reign forever (2 Samuel 7). Psalm 110:1 says that David's Lord sits at God's right hand until his enemies are made a footstool. Jesus applied this psalm to himself (Matthew 22:41-45). He is the king who has been raised and exalted, who rules now over his church and the universe, and who will return to judge and to bring all things under his feet. As king, Christ governs us by his word and Spirit, defends us from our enemies, and will finally subdue all things.

Why do the three offices matter? Because they correct our one-sided views of Jesus. Some think of him only as a teacher, a moral guide who gave us a better way to live. That is the prophet without the priest or king. Others think of him only as a Savior who forgives sins, but they do not think of him as one who governs their lives. That is the priest without the king. Others think of him mostly as a ruler, but forget that he came to die. The full Jesus is prophet, priest, and king.

The three offices also show what it means to be a Christian. We are united to Christ, and so we share in his offices. Believers are taught by his word, so we listen as prophets who speak the truth. We are priests who offer spiritual sacrifices (1 Peter 2:5, 9). And we are kings who will reign with him, as we learn to rule our own hearts and serve others (Revelation 1:6; 5:10). The offices are not only a way to understand Jesus. They are a way to understand our calling in him.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three passages you read today are linked by a single idea: God's final word to his people comes through a person, and that person holds the highest offices in Israel.

Start with Deuteronomy 18. Moses speaks to a people who are afraid of hearing God's voice directly. At Horeb they said, "Let me not hear again the voice of the LORD my God." God answered that he would send a prophet like Moses, one who would speak all that God commanded. The people are told, "It is to him you shall listen." Notice what is required: listening. The whole law of Moses was incomplete, and it pointed forward to a prophet who would complete it. The next verses of the chapter add a stern warning that anyone who does not listen to that prophet will answer for it.

Psalm 110 is the most quoted psalm in the New Testament. In it, David speaks of a figure he calls "my Lord," someone greater than David himself. This person sits at God's right hand, which is the place of supreme honor. He is a king, who rules in the midst of his enemies, and he is a priest forever. In Israel, the two roles were kept separate, and kings who tried to act as

priests were judged (2 Chronicles 26:16-21). Yet here is one who holds both, and he is established not by descent but by the oath of God. The psalm asks the reader to think about who this could be.

Hebrews 1 gives the answer. The author opens his letter by contrasting the many partial words of the prophets with the one final Word of the Son. Then he describes the Son in three ways: heir of all things and creator of the world (a kingly role), the radiance of God's glory (a prophetic role, as the one who reveals God), and the one who made purification for sins (a priestly role). Then he says that the Son "sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high," echoing Psalm 110:1. All three offices come together in a single verse.

Taken together, the passages give a picture of fullness. God spoke in the past in pieces. Now he has spoken in a person. The Son is not just one more messenger. He is the message.

STEP 5

Connection

The New Testament repeatedly applies these three offices to Jesus. The crowds said, "This is indeed the Prophet who is to come into the world" (John 6:14). Peter preached that Jesus is the prophet like Moses (Acts 3:22-23), and Stephen did the same (Acts 7:37). Jesus claimed Psalm 110 for himself in front of the Sanhedrin (Mark 14:62). Hebrews 4:14-5:10 and 7:1-28 expound his priesthood. Revelation 19:16 calls him "King of kings and Lord of lords."

STEP 6

Application

Listen to Jesus as your prophet. Choose a passage in the Gospels today and ask what he is saying to you.

Draw near to him as your priest. Bring a specific need or sin to him in prayer, trusting that he intercedes for you.

Submit to him as your king. Ask whether there is any area of your life that you have not yet put under his rule.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus as your prophet, priest, and king, and tell him which of these you most need today.

Ask him to speak, and listen.

Ask him to rule you and help you obey.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 27

"The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen."

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

DAY 185 · WEEK 27

Deuteronomy 17:1-18:22

Kings, priests, prophets, the offices typology

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 42 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 17:1-18:22. Having paused to see where the offices lead, return now to the text itself. This reading describes how judges, kings, priests, and prophets are to function in Israel. Look especially at the instructions for the king.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses sets out how Israel's offices are to work. Chapter 17 covers the administration of justice and, remarkably, a law for kings, though Israel has no king yet. Chapter 18 covers the Levitical priests and the prophets. Together they describe how God intended to govern his people under his law, with every office limited by the word of God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. A person accused of idolatry is to be convicted on "the evidence of two witnesses or of three witnesses" (17:2-7).
2. Hard cases are to be taken to the Levitical priests and the judge at the place the LORD chooses (17:8-13).
3. "When you come to the land… and you say, I will set a king over me, like all the nations that are around me, you may indeed set a king over you whom the LORD your God will choose" (17:14-15).
4. The king "must not acquire many horses for himself… neither shall he acquire many wives for himself… nor shall he acquire for himself excessive silver and gold" (17:16-17).
5. He is to write for himself a copy of the law and "read in it all the days of his life" (17:18-19).

6. This is so that "his heart may not be lifted up above his brothers" (17:20).
7. The Levites have no inheritance among their brothers: "The LORD is his inheritance" (18:1-8).
8. Israel is forbidden to practice divination, sorcery, or spiritism. The LORD will raise up a prophet like Moses, and false prophets are to be tested by whether their words come to pass (18:9-22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The law of the king is one of the most remarkable passages in the Old Testament. Written centuries before Israel's first king, it limits his power in advance. The king is to be chosen by God, he is to be one of the people, he must not accumulate horses, wives, or wealth, and he must read the law every day. The only checks on ancient kings were usually other kings. Here the check is the word of God.

Look at the three prohibitions. Horses represent military power, and especially a return to Egypt, the source of horses. Wives represent political alliances, and also divided loyalties. Silver and gold represent wealth and the temptation to trust in it. Each is a way of relying on something other than God. Solomon, the wisest of kings, violated all three, and his story shows what happens when the instructions are ignored.

The king's key duty is positive: he must write out a copy of the law with his own hand, keep it with him, and read it all his life. The result is humility, so that "his heart may not be lifted up above his brothers." A king who knows the law knows that he is under it. The best leaders are those who submit to a higher authority.

The prophet is the last office. Moses promises that God will raise up a prophet like him. In the immediate sense, this is a promise of a line of prophets who will speak for God. But the singular, "a prophet like me," and the later note in Deuteronomy 34:10 that no prophet had yet risen like Moses, led Israel to look for one greater prophet. The test of a true prophet is simple: his words must be God's words, and they must prove true.

The Levites' situation is described again: no inheritance, because the LORD is their inheritance. Those who serve at God's altar share in the offerings. They live by faith.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the king who does not seek his own glory, who humbled himself and became obedient to death (Philippians 2:6-8). He is the king who knew the law perfectly and answered temptation with the words of Deuteronomy. He is the prophet like Moses, and

Peter says so in Acts 3:22. He is also the one who calls false prophets to account (Matthew 7:15-20), and who is himself the standard by which they are measured (1 John 4:1-3).

STEP 6

Application

If you have any role of authority, read the law of the king as a mirror. Where are you tempted toward power, status, or wealth?

Commit to a daily reading of Scripture, as the king was to do.

Test what you hear from teachers against the word of God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from the pride of power.
- Ask him to make you a daily reader of his word.
- Thank Jesus, the true king and prophet who humbled himself for you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 27

"The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen."

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

DAY 186 · WEEK 27

Deuteronomy 19:1-21:23

Cities of refuge; warfare; difficult cases

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 19:1-21:23. These chapters deal with cities of refuge, witnesses, warfare, and a series of difficult cases. Read them slowly. Some are hard, and they should be understood in the context of ancient Israel as a nation under the old covenant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Moses continues applying the law to civil life. He repeats the provision for cities of refuge, stresses the need for honest witnesses, sets out rules for warfare, and addresses a series of specific situations: an unsolved murder, a captive woman, the rights of the firstborn, a rebellious son, and the body of an executed criminal. These cases show how the law dealt with the real complications of community life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Three cities of refuge are to be set apart, with roads prepared and room for three more if the territory expands (19:1-10).
2. “A single witness shall not suffice… only on the evidence of two witnesses or of three witnesses shall a charge be established” (19:15).
3. A false witness is to receive the punishment that he intended for the accused (19:16-21).
4. Before battle, the priest is to say, “Hear, O Israel, today you are drawing near for battle against your enemies: let not your heart faint. Do not fear” (20:1-4).
5. Those who are afraid, newly married, or have just built a house are excused from battle (20:5-9).

6. When a corpse is found in the field, the elders of the nearest city must wash their hands and say, “Our hands did not shed this blood” (21:1-9).
7. Firstborn sons have a right to a double portion, even if their father prefers another wife’s son (21:15-17).
8. “A hanged man is cursed by God,” and his body must not remain overnight on the tree (21:22-23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

These chapters show that Israel’s law was not a code of rigid rules but a system for taking human life, truth, and community seriously. The cities of refuge protect the innocent. The rule of two or three witnesses protects the accused. The penalty for false witnesses, to receive what they meant for others, is a strict deterrent. Together, they show a concern for justice that was remarkable in the ancient world.

Notice the tenderness of the rules of war. A priest tells the soldiers not to be afraid, because “the LORD your God is he who goes with you.” Men who have just married or built a house are sent home, so that they do not die before enjoying what they have started. Even the fearful are released, so that their fear does not spread. This is not the rhetoric of a war machine. It is a view of war as a grave and limited matter.

The case of the unsolved murder is a striking picture of communal responsibility. When someone is found dead and no one knows who killed him, the nearest town is responsible for making atonement. The elders wash their hands over a heifer whose neck is broken, and pray, “Forgive, O LORD, your people Israel.” It shows that bloodshed pollutes a community, and that someone must acknowledge it.

The rule about the firstborn protects a son from the favoritism of a father. Even the unloved wife’s son has his rights. God’s law is concerned with fairness inside the family.

The last verse, 21:23, is the most important for what comes later. A body hanged on a tree was cursed, and it was to be buried by sundown, so that the land would not be defiled. The person was cursed “by God.” It was a mark of the deepest shame. The New Testament sees this as a description of what Christ would bear.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Deuteronomy 21:23 in Galatians 3:13: “Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us.” Peter says that Jesus “bore our sins in his body on the tree” (1 Peter 2:24). The requirement of two or three witnesses is quoted by Jesus (Matthew 18:16)

and Paul (2 Corinthians 13:1). The cities of refuge point to Christ as our refuge (Hebrews 6:18). Jesus told his disciples, “Do not be afraid,” as he sent them out.

STEP 6

Application

Think about how you treat people in disputes. Are you fair and honest in what you say about them?

Read Galatians 3:13 and thank Christ for taking the curse in your place.

If there is fear in your heart, hear the priest’s words from 20:4: “The LORD your God is he who goes with you.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for becoming a curse for you on the tree.
- Ask God to make you honest and fair in your dealings.
- Ask him to go with you into the battles you face.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 27

“The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen.”

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

DAY 187 · WEEK 27

Deuteronomy 22:1-25:19

Social and moral laws, justice in covenant community

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 92 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 22:1-25:19. This is the longest section of specific laws. It covers everyday matters of community life, from lost animals to marriage, to honest weights. Read it as a picture of how God cares about the details of ordinary life.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters read like a collection of case laws. They touch on how to treat a neighbor's property, sexual morality, who may belong to the assembly of the LORD, hygiene in the camp, treatment of the poor and the foreigner, marriage and divorce, and business ethics. Some of the laws are hard to understand, as they come from a very different time and culture. But the principles behind them are clear.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You shall not see your brother's ox or his sheep going astray, and hide yourselves from them. You shall take them back to your brother" (22:1).
2. "You shall make a parapet for your roof, that you may not bring the guilt of blood upon your house" (22:8).
3. "You shall not plow with an ox and a donkey together" (22:10).
4. A man who is newly married is to be free from military service for a year, "to be happy with his wife" (24:5).
5. "You shall not oppress a hired servant who is poor and needy" (24:14-15).
6. "Fathers shall not be put to death because of their children, nor shall children be put to death because of their fathers" (24:16).

7. “When you reap your harvest in your field and forget a sheaf… it shall be for the sojourner, the fatherless, and the widow” (24:19).

8. “You shall have a full and just weight, a full and just measure” (25:13-16). “You shall blot out the memory of Amalek” (25:17-19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The laws of these chapters show the extent of God’s concern. He cares about a lost ox, a house roof, a pair of unlike animals, the wages of a day laborer, the way a person lends, and how fair a merchant’s scale is. Nothing is too small. This is a God who is holy in the market as well as in the temple.

The first law sets the tone: if you see your neighbor’s animal wandering, you must take it back. You cannot say, “It’s not my problem.” To love your neighbor means taking active responsibility for his welfare. The same principle shows up in the roof parapet. Because roofs were used as living space, a house owner has to make them safe. If you build a house, you take responsibility for the safety of anyone who enters it.

Several laws protect the vulnerable. The hired servant must be paid on the same day, because he is poor and depends on the wages. The gleaning laws leave behind some of the harvest for the poor. A creditor may not enter a debtor’s home to take a pledge, nor keep his cloak overnight. Foreigners, widows, and orphans are not to be denied justice. Each of these says, “Remember that you were a slave in Egypt.” Generosity is grounded in redemption.

A line in 24:16 is a landmark: each person is responsible for his own sin. In a world where families were often punished together, this was a significant principle. It shows that God’s justice is personal.

The call for honest weights and measures says that business ethics is a matter of worship. “For all who do such things, all who act dishonestly, are an abomination to the LORD your God.” The God of Israel cares what your scale says.

The section ends with a reminder of Amalek, the nation that attacked the weak and tired at the rear of Israel’s column when they came out of Egypt. This is the theme again: God is the defender of the weak.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said that the second great commandment is to love your neighbor as yourself, and in the parable of the Good Samaritan he extended “neighbor” to anyone in need (Luke 10:25-37). Paul quotes the law about the ox, “You shall not muzzle an ox when it treads out the grain,” to

support paying those who preach (1 Corinthians 9:9). James 5:4 echoes the law about unpaid wages. Jesus' compassion for the weak, the hungry, and the foreigner is the fulfillment of these laws.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether there is a "lost ox" in your life, something of a neighbor's that you could help return.

Review your business and financial dealings. Are your weights and measures honest?

Think about how you treat workers, and whether there is someone you should pay or tip more fairly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to make you honest, fair, and generous in practical ways.
- Tell him one way you want to love a neighbor this week.
- Thank Jesus for his compassion.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 27

"The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen."

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

DAY 188 · WEEK 27

Deuteronomy 26:1-28:14

Firstfruits; the blessings of obedience

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 49 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 26:1-28:14. This reading covers the firstfruits offering, a covenant ceremony at Ebal and Gerizim, and the first part of the great blessings and curses. Read the confession in 26:5-10 aloud as a creed.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The long section of laws comes to an end with a ritual and a ceremony. In chapter 26, Moses describes the firstfruits offering that Israelites are to bring when they enter the land, including a short statement of faith to be recited. In chapter 27, he commands the people to set up large stones when they cross the Jordan and to pronounce blessings and curses at Mount Gerizim and Mount Ebal. Chapter 28 begins the blessings and curses themselves, and you read the blessings first.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The Israelite is to bring the firstfruits to the place that the LORD chooses and say, “A wandering Aramean was my father” (26:1-5).
2. The creed tells the story: Egypt, affliction, the cry to the LORD, the exodus, the land, and the firstfruits (26:5-10).
3. “And you shall rejoice in all the good that the LORD your God has given to you” (26:11).
4. This day the LORD your God commands you to do these statutes… “You have declared today that the LORD is your God… and the LORD has declared today that you are a people for his treasured possession” (26:16-19).
5. The people are to set up stones on Mount Ebal, plaster them, and write on them all the words of the law (27:1-8).

6. Six tribes are to stand on Gerizim for the blessing and six on Ebal for the curse (27:11-14).
7. The Levites are to recite curses, and all the people say "Amen" (27:15-26).
8. "And all these blessings shall come upon you and overtake you, if you obey the voice of the LORD your God" (28:2). "The LORD will make you the head and not the tail" (28:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The confession in chapter 26 is a brilliant piece of teaching. It tells the whole story of salvation in a few sentences. "A wandering Aramean was my father." It starts with the humility of Jacob. Then it recalls the slavery, the cry, the rescue, and the gift of the land. And then the worshiper says, "Behold, now I bring the firstfruits of the ground that you, O LORD, have given me." The offering is a response to the story.

This is how all Christian giving should work. We are not buying God's favor. We are returning a portion of what he has given because of what he has done. Worship rests on remembering.

The ceremony at Ebal and Gerizim is a dramatic act of covenant renewal. The people are divided on two mountains, with the Levites and the ark in the valley between. Curses are read from one side, blessings from the other. The curses listed in chapter 27 deal with secret sins: idolatry, dishonoring parents, moving boundary markers, taking bribes. After each one, the people say "Amen." They are agreeing to the consequences. It is a vivid way of saying that no one can say later that he did not know.

The blessings in chapter 28 are expansive. Blessing in the city and in the field, in the womb and the harvest, in coming in and going out. The pattern is of a life under God's favor that touches everything. Verse 13 says, "The LORD will make you the head and not the tail." Yet it is conditional: "if you obey." Everything depends on the heart's response.

It is important to read this in light of the whole book. Moses has said that Israel was stubborn and that the land was a gift of grace. The blessings are not wages. They are what happens in a life lived within God's goodness. The tragedy that follows is that Israel does not obey, and the curses fall.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that Christ has redeemed us from the curse of the law, so that in Christ Jesus the blessing of Abraham might come to the Gentiles (Galatians 3:13-14). Ephesians 1:3 says that God "has blessed us in Christ with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places." The Amen

of the people finds its echo in 2 Corinthians 1:20, where all the promises of God find their "Yes" in Christ, and "through him is our Amen." Revelation 5:14 shows the living creatures saying "Amen."

STEP 6

Application

Write out your own short account of God's work in your life, in the pattern of 26:5-10. Say it aloud as a prayer.

Make an offering of thanks, as a response and not as a payment.

Think about the "secret sins" of chapter 27. Is there one that you need to bring into the light?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring God a portion of what he has given you, and tell him what that is.
- Thank him for blessing you in Christ with every spiritual blessing.
- Ask him to let your "Amen" be true.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 27

"The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen."

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

DAY 189 · WEEK 27

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Deuteronomy 18:15 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen."

DEUTERONOMY 18:15

REST

Meditation

Deuteronomy 18:15 is a promise and a command in a single sentence. It was spoken by Moses near the end of his life, and it is quoted in the New Testament as a promise fulfilled in Jesus.

"The LORD your God will raise up for you." The prophet is a gift from God. He is not self-appointed. God takes the initiative to speak to his people, and he does it by raising up someone for them. The whole idea of revelation begins with God.

"A prophet like me." Moses was the greatest prophet of the Old Testament. God spoke with him face to face. He mediated the covenant, performed signs, led the people out of Egypt, and gave the law. To be "like Moses" is a high standard. Deuteronomy 34:10 says that no prophet had yet arisen like him. The promise looks beyond the line of ordinary prophets to someone who would be like Moses, and greater.

“From among you, from your brothers.” The prophet will be one of them. He is a true human being, a member of the covenant family. This points to the incarnation, in which God’s Son became a man.

“It is to him you shall listen.” The command is simple: listen. The Father said the same thing at the transfiguration, when Moses and Elijah appeared with Jesus: “This is my beloved Son; listen to him” (Mark 9:7). The prophet like Moses has come, and he is the Son.

To be a Christian is to be a listener of Jesus. Spend today in quiet listening. Read the Gospels slowly, and ask him to speak.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read more of Moses’ sermons in Deuteronomy. You saw that the Lord’s election of Israel was not based on their righteousness, and you read of the golden calf and Moses’ intercession again. You prayed through the second half of Psalm 78, which ends with the choice of David as shepherd. You read laws about worship, false prophets, the tithe, the release of debts, and the care of the poor, and you studied the three offices of Christ as prophet, priest, and king. You read the law of the king and the promise of a prophet like Moses, and a long series of laws about justice, warfare, and daily life. You read the firstfruits creed, the covenant ceremony at Ebal and Gerizim, and the first blessings of obedience. The week taught that God’s law shapes every part of life, and that all of Israel’s offices find their fulfillment in Christ.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Moses promised a prophet like himself, and Jesus is that prophet. What is the difference between knowing about Jesus and listening to him?

The three offices of prophet, priest, and king show different sides of Christ’s work. Which of the three do you most need to lean on at this stage of your life, and why?

The firstfruits creed ends with rejoicing in “all the good that the LORD your God has given.” What good things has God given you that you have not stopped to thank him for?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus as your prophet, priest, and king.

Ask him to speak today and to help you listen.

Rest in him this Sabbath.

DAY 190 · WEEK 28

Psalm 119:1-48

The word of God as lamp, loving Scripture

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:1-48. This is the longest psalm and the longest chapter in the Bible, and it is a prayer in praise of God's word. You will read it in four sections over the next week. Today, read slowly, perhaps a few stanzas at a time, and notice the many words for God's word.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 119 is an acrostic. It has twenty-two sections of eight verses each, one for each letter of the Hebrew alphabet, and in each section every verse begins with that letter. The author is not named, though the psalmist speaks as a young man who has faced mockery and affliction. Nearly every verse uses one of eight or so words for God's revealed will: law, testimonies, precepts, statutes, commandments, rules, word, and promise. It follows Deuteronomy in the plan because the whole book of Deuteronomy is a sermon on loving and keeping God's word.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed are those whose way is blameless, who walk in the law of the LORD!" (v. 1).
2. "How can a young man keep his way pure? By guarding it according to your word" (v. 9).
3. "I have stored up your word in my heart, that I might not sin against you" (v. 11).
4. "Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of your law" (v. 18).
5. "I am a sojourner on the earth; hide not your commandments from me!" (v. 19).
6. "My soul clings to the dust; give me life according to your word!" (v. 25).
7. "I will run in the way of your commandments when you enlarge my heart!" (v. 32).

8 “Turn my eyes from looking at worthless things; and give me life in your ways” (v. 37). “And I shall walk in a wide place, for I have sought your precepts” (v. 45).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with blessing, and the word is the first word of the Psalter too (Psalm 1:1). The blessed are those who walk in the law of the LORD. This is not a grim path. It is the way of life. The psalmist loves God’s word, and he says so again and again. For him, the law is not an external burden. It is a delight.

Notice the psalmist’s honesty about his need. “My soul clings to the dust.” “Open my eyes.” “Enlarge my heart.” He cannot keep the word by his own strength. He asks God to help him understand it, to love it, and to keep it. The psalm is full of prayer. Reading the Bible is not an exercise in willpower. It is a conversation with God, who must give understanding and desire.

The verse about the young man is among the best-known. How can he keep his way pure? By living according to God’s word. The method is stated in verse 11: “I have stored up your word in my heart.” Memorization and meditation are the way that Scripture shapes behavior. We guard our way by filling our hearts with God’s word, so that when temptation comes, it is already there.

The psalmist also faces opposition. Proud people mock him and princes sit and plot against him. Yet he says that he will speak of God’s testimonies before kings and not be put to shame. His confidence is not in his own reputation, but in the promise. Faith in the word gives courage to speak.

The first section ends with a prayer for freedom: “I shall walk in a wide place.” The world sees obedience as narrow. The psalmist sees it as wide. God’s commands do not confine him. They take him out of the narrow place of sin and into spaciousness.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Blessed rather are those who hear the word of God and keep it” (Luke 11:28), and “If you abide in my word, you are truly my disciples” (John 8:31). He answered temptation with the word of God. Paul says that all Scripture is breathed out by God (2 Timothy 3:16). The psalmist’s prayer to open his eyes is answered when Jesus “opened their minds to understand the Scriptures” (Luke 24:45).

STEP 6

Application

Pick one verse from today's reading to store in your heart, and write it on a card.

Pray verse 18 before you open your Bible: "Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things."

Ask whether you see God's commands as narrow or wide.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you want to walk in his word and love it.
- Ask him to open your eyes to wonderful things in it.
- Ask him to store his word in your heart so that you do not sin against him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 28

"The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law."

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

DAY 191 · WEEK 28

Psalm 119:49-96

Comfort in affliction; the commandments as songs

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:49-96. Today's section moves from joy in the word to comfort in suffering. Notice how the psalmist speaks of affliction.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second section of the great acrostic psalm continues the theme with a new emphasis. The psalmist is under pressure from the arrogant and wicked, and he turns to God's word for comfort. These verses include some of the most personal confessions in the psalm, as he describes his affliction and his dependence on God's promises.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Remember your word to your servant, in which you have made me hope" (v. 49).
2. "This is my comfort in my affliction, that your promise gives me life" (v. 50).
3. "Your statutes have been my songs in the house of my sojourning" (v. 54).
4. "I have considered my ways and turned my feet to your testimonies; I hasten and do not delay to keep your commandments" (vv. 59-60).
5. "It is good for me that I was afflicted, that I might learn your statutes" (v. 71).
6. "I know, O LORD, that your rules are righteous, and that in faithfulness you have afflicted me" (v. 75).
7. "If your law had not been my delight, I would have perished in my affliction" (v. 92).
8. "I have seen a limit to all perfection, but your commandment is exceedingly broad" (v. 96).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This section is a school of comfort. The psalmist is in distress, but he finds that God's word is a comfort. "This is my comfort in my affliction, that your promise gives me life." The promise is not a vague hope. It is a specific word that God has spoken, and it has the power to give life when everything else seems to be dying.

Verses 54 and 55 are striking. The psalmist calls God's statutes "songs" in the house of his sojourning. A traveler's house might be a poor place, but it is filled with song. The word can turn any dwelling into a place of worship. And at night, he remembers God's name and keeps his law.

The center of the section is verses 67, 71, and 75, where the psalmist reflects on his suffering. "Before I was afflicted I went astray, but now I keep your word." "It is good for me that I was afflicted." It is a hard thing to say, and he does not say it lightly. But he has learned that his troubles were God's way of teaching him. In faithfulness, God has afflicted him. Affliction was not a sign of God's absence. It was a form of his care.

This is not a general claim that all suffering is God's discipline. The psalmist is speaking from his own experience, and he is not claiming to be sinless. But he points to a truth that the whole Bible affirms: God uses hardship to draw us closer to himself. As Hebrews 12:10-11 says, he disciplines us "for our good, that we may share his holiness."

The section ends with a sweeping statement of the word's scope: "I have seen a limit to all perfection, but your commandment is exceedingly broad." Everything else in life has limits. The word of God does not. There is always more to learn, and more to love.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that "suffering produces endurance, and endurance produces character, and character produces hope" (Romans 5:3-4). Hebrews 12:5-11 quotes Proverbs about the Lord's discipline. Jesus is the one who "learned obedience through what he suffered" (Hebrews 5:8). Jesus said, "These things I have spoken to you, that in me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world" (John 16:33).

STEP 6

Application

Think of a hard time that taught you something about God. Thank him for it.

Choose one promise from Scripture to hold on to in a current difficulty.

Sing or hum a psalm as you go about your day, as the psalmist did in the house of his sojourning.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God where you need his promise to give you life.
- Thank him for what he has taught you in affliction.
- Ask him to make his commands your songs.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 28

"The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law."

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

DAY 192 · WEEK 28

Deuteronomy 28:15-68

The curses of disobedience, the weight of covenant

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 28:15-68. This is the longest and most sobering passage in the book. It describes the curses that will fall on Israel if they break the covenant. Read it carefully, and notice what is at the heart of the list.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The blessings of 28:1-14 take only fourteen verses. The curses take fifty-four. Moses is not trying to scare the people but to make sure they understand how serious the covenant is. The curses begin with general disaster and grow to include defeat, siege, famine, disease, and finally exile. The chapter is the most detailed warning in the Old Testament, and the prophets will return to it again and again.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “But if you will not obey the voice of the LORD your God or be careful to do all his commandments… then all these curses shall come upon you” (28:15).
2. “Cursed shall you be in the city, and cursed shall you be in the field” (28:16-19).
3. The LORD will send confusion and frustration in all that you undertake (28:20).
4. The LORD will strike with disease, drought, and defeat before enemies (28:21-26).
5. “You shall be driven mad by the sight that your eyes see” (28:34).
6. A foreign nation will devour the land, and a siege will cause such hunger that people eat their own children (28:49-57).
7. “The LORD will scatter you among all peoples, from one end of the earth to the other” (28:64).

8 “Because you did not serve the LORD your God with joyfulness and gladness of heart, because of the abundance of all things, therefore you shall serve your enemies” (28:47-48).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Read this passage slowly, and do not rush to explain it away. It is meant to be heavy. The curses mirror the blessings, point for point. Where the blessings spoke of rain, harvest, and victory, the curses speak of drought, blight, and defeat. The pattern says that the covenant is real, and that its terms are real. To live apart from God is to lose the goods that he gives.

The turning point is verse 47: “Because you did not serve the LORD your God with joyfulness and gladness of heart, because of the abundance of all things.” The root of the failure is not a dramatic act of rebellion. It is ingratitude. A people who have everything do not thank the giver. The loss of joy in God comes before the loss of everything else.

The curses also include a reversal of the exodus. “The LORD will bring you back in ships to Egypt… and there you shall offer yourselves for sale to your enemies as male and female slaves” (28:68). The people who were rescued from Egypt are sent back into slavery. The covenant that gave them freedom, if broken, takes it away. It is a chilling statement of what covenant unfaithfulness means.

The curses are fulfilled in Israel’s history. The northern kingdom fell to Assyria, and Judah fell to Babylon. The prophets saw the exile as the working out of these very words (see 2 Kings 17 and Daniel 9:11-13). The curses were not idle threats. They happened.

Yet this is not the end of the story. Deuteronomy 30 will promise that, after the curses, God will bring his people back if they return to him. The book of Deuteronomy is balanced between warning and hope, and the warning exists in order to bring people to repentance.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that “all who rely on works of the law are under a curse” (Galatians 3:10), quoting Deuteronomy 27:26, and then that “Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us” (Galatians 3:13). Jesus took the covenant curses on himself at the cross: the darkness, the thirst, the abandonment, and the cry, “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” Romans 8:1 says there is no condemnation for those in Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Read the passage as a measure of what Christ endured on your behalf. Thank him.

Ask whether there is a lack of joy and gladness in your service of God. Pray for restoration.

Spend time in gratitude, naming the “abundance” that God has given you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Christ for bearing the curse in your place.
- Confess where you have served God without joy.
- Ask him for a grateful heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 28

“The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law.”

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

DAY 193 · WEEK 28

Deuteronomy 29:1-31:29

Covenant renewed; the secret things belong to God

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 29:1-31:29. In this reading, Moses calls Israel to renew the covenant, gives the famous "secret things" verse, and then hands over leadership to Joshua. Notice the call to choose life.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the blessings and curses, Moses gathers the people for a covenant renewal ceremony in the land of Moab. Chapter 29 describes the covenant, with a warning against secret idolatry and a prophecy of exile. Chapter 30 gives a promise of restoration, a call to choose life, and the statement that God's word is near. Chapter 31 deals with the transfer of leadership to Joshua, the writing of the law, and the foretelling of Israel's future rebellion.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You have seen all that the LORD did before your eyes in the land of Egypt... But to this day the LORD has not given you a heart to understand or eyes to see or ears to hear" (29:2-4).
2. "It is not with you alone that I am making this sworn covenant, but with whoever is standing here with us today... and with whoever is not here with us today" (29:14-15).
3. "The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law" (29:29).
4. "When all these things come upon you... and you return to the LORD your God... then the LORD your God will restore your fortunes and have compassion on you" (30:1-3).
5. "The LORD your God will circumcise your heart and the heart of your offspring, so that you will love the LORD your God with all your heart" (30:6).

6. “For this commandment that I command you today is not too hard for you, neither is it far off” (30:11).
7. “I have set before you life and death, blessing and curse. Therefore choose life, that you and your offspring may live” (30:19).
8. Moses commissions Joshua: “Be strong and courageous… It is the LORD who goes before you. He will be with you; he will not leave you or forsake you” (31:6-8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 29 begins with a startling observation: after all the miracles, Israel still lacks a heart to understand. Moses says that God had not given them “a heart to understand or eyes to see or ears to hear.” It is a surprising admission. Seeing miracles does not change the heart. Only God can do that. And this is exactly what chapter 30 promises: “The LORD your God will circumcise your heart.” The problem of the heart is solved by God’s own gift.

The “secret things” verse is a great statement about knowing and not knowing. There are things God has not told us, and we should not be anxious about them. And there are things he has revealed, which belong to us, so that we may obey. The secret things are God’s business. The revealed things are ours. It frees us from speculation and calls us to obedience.

Chapter 30 is the hope of the book. Even after the curses fall, even after exile, there is a way back. “When you return to the LORD your God… he will gather you.” Repentance is always possible. And the way is not impossible: “The word is very near you. It is in your mouth and in your heart, so that you can do it.” God’s call is not a distant puzzle. It is close at hand.

Then comes the choice. “I have set before you life and death, blessing and curse. Therefore choose life.” Moses puts the whole book into one sentence. The people are not forced. They are invited. And choosing life is described as “loving the LORD your God, obeying his voice, and holding fast to him.”

Chapter 31 turns to the future. Moses commissions Joshua and tells him not to be afraid. He writes the law down and places it beside the ark. And he tells the people that after his death they will become corrupt. The tone is realistic. God knows that they will fail. He gives a song, which you will read tomorrow, to be a witness against them.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Deuteronomy 30:11-14 in Romans 10:6-8 and applies it to the gospel: “The word is near you, in your mouth and in your heart (that is, the word of faith that we proclaim).” He says that Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes (Romans

10:4). Paul says that circumcision is of the heart (Romans 2:29), and Jesus said, “I came that they may have life and have it abundantly” (John 10:10). Hebrews 13:5 quotes 31:6: “I will never leave you nor forsake you.”

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of “secret things” that trouble you. Give them to God, and act on what is revealed.

Choose life today in one specific decision.

Take courage from God’s promise to Joshua. Receive it as spoken to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give God the secret things you do not understand.

Ask him to circumcise your heart so that you love him.

Thank him that he goes before you and will not leave you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 28

“The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law.”

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

DAY 194 · WEEK 28

Deuteronomy 31:30-32:52

The song of Moses, covenant lawsuit in poetry

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 67 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 31:30-32:52. This is the Song of Moses, a long poem that serves as a witness to Israel. Read it aloud if you can, and notice how it moves from praise to accusation to comfort.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

God has told Moses to write a song and teach it to Israel, so that it will be a witness against them when they turn away. The song is placed after the last of Moses' sermons. It is a poem in the form of a covenant lawsuit: it summons heaven and earth as witnesses, states God's faithfulness, charges Israel with unfaithfulness, announces judgment, and ends with a promise of vindication. After the song, God tells Moses to go up Mount Nebo and die.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give ear, O heavens, and I will speak, and let the earth hear the words of my mouth" (32:1).
2. "The Rock, his work is perfect, for all his ways are justice. A God of faithfulness and without iniquity, just and upright is he" (32:4).
3. "They have dealt corruptly with him; they are no longer his children because they are blemished" (32:5).
4. "Is not he your father, who created you, who made you and established you?" (32:6).
5. "The LORD's portion is his people, Jacob his allotted heritage" (32:9). He found him in a desert land… "he encircled him, he cared for him, he kept him as the apple of his eye" (32:10).

6. “Like an eagle that stirs up its nest, that flutters over its young, spreading out its wings, catching them, bearing them on its pinions” (32:11).
7. “But Jeshurun grew fat, and kicked… He forsook God who made him and scoffed at the Rock of his salvation” (32:15).
8. “See now that I, even I, am he, and there is no god beside me; I kill and I make alive… and there is none that can deliver out of my hand” (32:39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The song is a retelling of Israel’s story in miniature. God is the Rock, perfect and faithful. He found Israel in the wilderness, protected them like the apple of his eye, and carried them like an eagle carries its young. They grew fat in the land and forsook him. It is the same pattern you have seen throughout the wilderness story: grace, prosperity, rebellion, judgment.

The image of the eagle is beautiful. An eagle stirs up its nest so the young must fly, and then hovers beneath them, ready to catch them. It is a picture of God’s care that is both challenging and protective. He pushes his people out of comfort, and he does not let them fall.

The word “Rock” appears repeatedly. It is a name for God that stresses his stability and strength. Everything else in the song shifts, but the Rock does not. The nations’ gods are not rocks: “Their rock is not like our Rock” (32:31). In a world of change and disappointment, there is a foundation.

The accusation is heavy. Israel is called “a crooked and twisted generation” (32:5). The children have turned away from their father. This is a covenant lawsuit, with heaven and earth as the jury. But the sentence is not final. Verse 36 says, “The LORD will vindicate his people and have compassion on his servants.” The song moves from judgment to compassion. God’s last word is not wrath.

The final verses of the chapter return to Moses himself. He is told to go up Mount Nebo, look at the land, and die. He will not enter, “because you broke faith with me.” His own failure at Meribah has consequences. But the great leader receives a view of the land and a peaceful death, a last gift.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes the song in Romans 10:19 and 12:19, and 15:10, and in 1 Corinthians 10:22. Jesus compared himself to a hen gathering her chicks, and in the parable of the wicked tenants he spoke of the vineyard owner’s son, echoing Israel’s rejection. Revelation 15:3 says that the

redeemed sing “the song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb.” The Rock is Christ (1 Corinthians 10:4), and the foundation on which we build (Matthew 7:24-25).

STEP 6

Application

Read the song aloud once through. Notice which phrase speaks to you.

Ask whether you have grown “fat and kicked” in a season of ease. Return to the Rock.

Thank God for the image of the eagle, and for the ways he has both pushed and caught you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as the Rock whose work is perfect.
- Confess where you have forgotten the Rock of your salvation.
- Ask him to vindicate his people and have compassion on them.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 28

“The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law.”

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

DAY 195 · WEEK 28

Deuteronomy 33:1-34:12

Moses' final blessing; his death, the prophet yet to come

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 33:1-34:12. This is the end of the Pentateuch. Moses blesses the tribes and then climbs Mount Nebo to die. Read the last chapter slowly, and notice the final description of Moses.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the last day in the five books of Moses. Before he dies, Moses speaks a blessing over each of the tribes, much as Jacob did at the end of Genesis. Then the narrator describes his death on Mount Nebo, his burial, and a verdict on his life. The close of the book sets up the transition to Joshua and the conquest, but also leaves a hopeful question hanging: where is the prophet like Moses who is yet to come?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD came from Sinai and dawned from Seir upon us; he shone forth from Mount Paran" (33:2).
2. "Yes, he loved his people… and they followed in your steps, receiving direction from you" (33:3).
3. Moses blesses the tribes, including Judah: "Hear, O LORD, the voice of Judah" (33:7), and Levi, who is to teach Jacob God's rules and offer incense (33:8-11).
4. "The eternal God is your dwelling place, and underneath are the everlasting arms" (33:27).
5. "Happy are you, O Israel! Who is like you, a people saved by the LORD, the shield of your help, and the sword of your triumph?" (33:29).

6. Moses goes up from the plains of Moab to Mount Nebo, and the LORD shows him all the land (34:1-4).
7. "So Moses the servant of the LORD died there in the land of Moab, according to the word of the LORD" (34:5).
8. "And there has not arisen a prophet since in Israel like Moses, whom the LORD knew face to face" (34:10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The blessing of the tribes shows Moses as a father and a pastor to the end. His last words are not rebuke but blessing. After forty years of leading a difficult people, his final act is to bless them, one tribe after another. A good leader leaves the people with a benediction.

The most famous verse is 33:27: "The eternal God is your dwelling place, and underneath are the everlasting arms." It is a fitting summary of Moses' message. God is the home of his people, as Psalm 90 said at the start of this unit. And underneath are the everlasting arms, a picture of unseen support. When we fall, we fall into the hands of God.

The death of Moses is told with beautiful restraint. He climbs the mountain, sees the land, and dies "according to the word of the LORD." The Hebrew can also mean "by the mouth of the LORD," and the rabbis said he died by a kiss. He is buried by God himself, and "no one knows the place of his burial to this day." There is no tomb to venerate. He was not worshiped, and God made sure that no one would turn his grave into a shrine.

The last paragraph is the verdict. Moses was 120 years old, with unimpaired eyesight and vigor. The people wept for thirty days. And then comes the line that looks forward: "There has not arisen a prophet since in Israel like Moses, whom the LORD knew face to face." It is a statement of Moses' greatness, and it also leaves a longing. God had promised another prophet like Moses (18:15). The Pentateuch ends by saying that he has not yet come.

This is why the end of Deuteronomy is not an ending. It is a pause in a larger story. The Law has done its work. It has described the covenant, shown Israel's need, and pointed forward. The rest of the Bible waits for someone greater than Moses.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 3:5-6 says that Moses was faithful "as a servant in all God's house," but Christ is faithful "as a son over God's house." Jude 9 mentions a dispute about the body of Moses. At the transfiguration, Moses appears with Jesus and talks with him about his departure (Luke

9:30-31). John 1:17 says, “The law was given through Moses; grace and truth came through Jesus Christ.” The everlasting arms are now the arms of Christ, who took the children in his arms and blessed them (Mark 10:16).

STEP 6

Application

Spend time with the verse “The eternal God is your dwelling place, and underneath are the everlasting arms.” Where do you need to feel them?

Think about how you want to finish your own life of service. Is there a blessing you want to leave?

Thank God for Moses, and for the one who is greater than Moses.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that underneath you are his everlasting arms.
- Thank him for Jesus, the greater prophet.
- Ask him to teach you to finish well and leave a legacy of faith.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 28

“The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law.”

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

DAY 196 · WEEK 28

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Deuteronomy 29:29 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law."

DEUTERONOMY 29:29

REST

Meditation

Deuteronomy 29:29 is a verse about the limits of knowledge and the shape of obedience. It comes at the end of a chapter of warning, and it sets out a balance that every believer needs.

"The secret things belong to the LORD our God." There are things we do not know and cannot know. Why a particular event happened, how God's sovereignty and human responsibility work together, what is hidden in the future. These belong to God. This is not a rebuke. It is a relief. We are not required to carry the weight of knowing everything.

"But the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever." God has spoken. He has made known his character, his promises, and his commands. These are not for specialists alone, but for us and our children. The word "forever" means that the revealed things are a permanent possession. Scripture is a gift to every generation.

“That we may do all the words of this law.” The purpose of revelation is obedience. God does not give us his word only to satisfy curiosity. He gives it so that we may live by it. The practical question is never “What does God know?” but “What has God told me to do?”

For the Christian, the verse is an invitation to humility and to action. Some questions will not be answered in this life. But the gospel has been revealed in Christ, and what we need for life and godliness has been given (2 Peter 1:3). Stop worrying about the secret things. Do what is revealed.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the book of Deuteronomy. You read the long section of laws about justice, warfare, and daily life, and the ritual of the firstfruits with its creed. You read the covenant ceremony at Ebal and Gerizim, and the detailed curses of disobedience. You read Moses’ call to choose life and the promise that God would circumcise the heart. In the Psalms, you prayed through the first sections of Psalm 119, which praises the word of God as a source of purity and comfort. You read the Song of Moses, with its image of God as the Rock and the eagle, and then Moses’ last blessing and his death on Mount Nebo. The week taught that God’s word is near, that the heart needs his help to love it, and that even in judgment, he leaves a way back.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Moses said, “The word is very near you, in your mouth and in your heart.” What practical difference does it make to you that God’s word is near, and not far off?

The book of Deuteronomy ends with the statement that no prophet had arisen like Moses. How does the New Testament answer that longing, and why does it matter?

Psalm 119 is a long prayer of love for God’s word. How would you describe your own feelings about Scripture, and what would help you to love it more?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give God the things you do not understand and ask him for trust.

Tell him what you want to obey that he has shown you.

Rest in him today.

DAY 197 · WEEK 29

Psalm 119:97-144

The commandments as wisdom, sweeter than honey

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:97-144. Today's section includes one of the most famous verses in the psalm, verse 105. Read it as a prayer from someone who loves God's word and finds it a guide in the dark.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The third section of Psalm 119 begins with a cry of love: "Oh how I love your law!" It speaks of wisdom, guidance, and zeal. The psalmist is surrounded by wicked people who do not keep God's word, and he is grieved by their disobedience. Yet he finds in Scripture light, wisdom, and sweetness, and he holds to it with passion.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh how I love your law! It is my meditation all the day" (v. 97).
2. "Your commandment makes me wiser than my enemies, for it is ever with me" (v. 98).
3. "I have more understanding than all my teachers, for your testimonies are my meditation" (v. 99).
4. "How sweet are your words to my taste, sweeter than honey to my mouth!" (v. 103).
5. "Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path" (v. 105).
6. "I have sworn an oath and confirmed it, to keep your righteous rules" (v. 106).
7. "The unfolding of your words gives light; it imparts understanding to the simple" (v. 130).
8. "My eyes shed streams of tears, because people do not keep your law" (v. 136).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This section opens with an outpouring of love. The psalmist says it is his meditation all day long. It is not a duty that he squeezes in. It is the way he thinks. And the result is wisdom. He is wiser than his enemies, has more insight than his teachers, and understands more than the elders. These are not boasts about his intellect. He attributes it all to the word. The person who meditates on Scripture gains a wisdom that cleverness cannot give.

Verse 103 is one of the best descriptions of what it is to love the word: "How sweet are your words to my taste, sweeter than honey to my mouth." It is a picture of delight. God's word is not bitter medicine. It is food that we enjoy. In Ezekiel 3:3, the prophet eats a scroll and says it is as sweet as honey. In Revelation 10:9-10, John eats a scroll that is sweet in the mouth and bitter in the stomach. The word is sweet, but it can also be bitter, because it brings both joy and conviction.

Verse 105 is the best known: "Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path." It is a modest image. A lamp in the ancient world did not light a whole road. It showed the next few steps. This is how God usually guides us. We do not get a floodlight on the whole future. We get enough to take the next step. The word is for walking, not just for knowing.

Verse 130 says that the unfolding of God's words gives light to the simple. The word is not only for the educated. The humble and the simple can understand what is essential. God is not hiding his truth from them.

The last verses show the other side: the psalmist weeps because others do not keep the law. Love for God's word includes grief for those who reject it. A heart that is in tune with God will be broken by what breaks his.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the light of the world (John 8:12), and he said, "Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness." John says that the Word is the light that shines in the darkness (John 1:1-5). Paul says that the word of Christ should dwell in you richly (Colossians 3:16). Peter calls us to long for "the pure spiritual milk" of the word, "that by it you may grow up into salvation" (1 Peter 2:2). Jesus wept over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41).

STEP 6

Application

Memorize verse 105. Say it before you go out this week.

Ask what the "next step" is that the lamp is showing you now.

Let your heart be moved for those who do not know God's word. Pray for someone by name.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you love about his word, and what you find hard about it.
- Ask him for understanding as you meditate on it today.
- Ask him to give you a heart for those who do not know him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 29

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

JOSHUA 1:9

DAY 198 · WEEK 29

Psalm 119:145-176

With my whole heart I cry; your word is my hope

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Psalm · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:145-176. This is the last section of the longest psalm. It is a series of cries for help, and it ends in a surprising way. Read the last verse carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The final section of Psalm 119 is full of urgent prayer. The psalmist rises before dawn to cry out, and he prays at night. He is pursued by those who are far from God's law, and yet he finds that God is near. The psalm ends not with a triumphant note, but with a confession that he has gone astray like a lost sheep, and a plea for the shepherd to seek him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "With my whole heart I cry; answer me, O LORD! I will keep your statutes" (v. 145).
2. "I rose before dawn and cried for help; I hoped in your words" (v. 147).
3. "You are near, O LORD, and all your commandments are true" (v. 151).
4. "The sum of your word is truth, and every one of your righteous rules endures forever" (v. 160).
5. "Great peace have those who love your law; nothing can make them stumble" (v. 165).
6. "I rejoice at your word like one who finds great spoil" (v. 162).
7. "Let my cry come before you, O LORD; give me understanding according to your word!" (v. 169).
8. "I have gone astray like a lost sheep; seek your servant, for I do not forget your commandments" (v. 176).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The closing section is a prayer of desperate faith. “With my whole heart I cry.” The psalmist prays early in the morning and late at night. He is not casual about prayer. He is urgent, and he bases his urgency on God’s word: “I hoped in your words.” The word is the ground of his hope. He prays what God has promised, and he trusts that God will do it.

Verse 151 is a short statement of great comfort: “You are near, O LORD.” Surrounded by those who persecute him, the psalmist holds on to the fact that God is near. He does not say that his circumstances have changed. He says that God is close, and that is enough.

Verse 160 is a profound statement about Scripture: “The sum of your word is truth.” The whole of it, taken together, is truth. Each part is true, and the whole is more than the parts. It is a good verse to remember as you read the Bible as a whole. Each passage is a piece of a single truth.

The great promise of verse 165 is peace: “Great peace have those who love your law; nothing can make them stumble.” This is not the peace of having no problems. It is the peace of those whose lives are rooted in God’s word. Though they may be shaken, they are not toppled.

Then the final verse. After 175 verses about loving, keeping, and delighting in God’s law, the psalmist ends with, “I have gone astray like a lost sheep; seek your servant.” It is a moving confession. The most devoted lover of the word still needs a shepherd. He cannot keep the law perfectly. He needs God to find him. And he says, “I do not forget your commandments.” Even a lost sheep remembers the shepherd’s voice.

This is where the law leads: not to self-righteousness, but to a cry for a shepherd.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told the parable of the lost sheep, in which the shepherd leaves the ninety-nine to seek the one (Luke 15:3-7), and he said, “I am the good shepherd” (John 10:11). Isaiah 53:6 says, “All we like sheep have gone astray… and the LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all.” Peter says, “You were straying like sheep, but have now returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls” (1 Peter 2:25). The psalmist’s last prayer is answered in Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Pray verse 176 as your own. Admit where you have gone astray, and ask the shepherd to seek you.

Think about your morning and evening habits of prayer. Is there a small way to deepen them?

Spend time thanking God for the peace of those who love his law.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Cry out to God with your whole heart, telling him where you have gone astray.

Thank Jesus, the good shepherd who found you.

Ask him to keep his word near you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 29

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

JOSHUA 1:9

DAY 199 · WEEK 29

Review and Reflection

Unit 7 review, Wilderness, Numbers & Deuteronomy

Year 1 · Unit 7 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one. You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might."
>
> DEUTERONOMY 6:4-5

REST

Meditation

Deuteronomy 6:4-5 is the unit's anchor verse. It is the greatest commandment, and the center of the book that you have just finished reading. Read it aloud once more before you continue.

"Hear, O Israel." The word "hear" in Hebrew is shema, and it means to listen and obey. After forty years of failing to listen, Israel is told again to hear. This is the way that every part of the covenant begins. Faith comes by hearing.

"The LORD our God, the LORD is one." There is one God. There is no rival, no partner, and no competing power. He is the LORD, the covenant name given at the burning bush. And he is "our God," bound to his people in love. The oneness of God is the foundation of Israel's life, and of the Christian faith.

"You shall love the LORD your God." The commandment is to love. This is not a request for mere compliance. The whole law, the sacrifices, the festivals, the justice, is meant to be the expression of love for God. Moses told the people many times in this book that obedience should flow from love.

"With all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might." The love is to be total. Heart is the center of thought and will. Soul is the whole self, life itself. Might is strength, resources, energy. Nothing is held back. Jesus added "mind" when he quoted the verse (Mark 12:30), but the sense is the same: everything we are belongs to God.

For the Christian, the verse is both a command and a promise. We cannot keep it on our own. But God promised in Deuteronomy 30:6 that he would circumcise our hearts so that we would love him. In Christ, that promise is fulfilled. The Spirit pours God's love into our hearts (Romans 5:5), and we love because he first loved us (1 John 4:19).

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 7 you have read the books of Numbers and Deuteronomy, the forty years in the wilderness and the sermons of Moses that prepared Israel for the land. You began with the census at Sinai and saw the camp arranged around the tabernacle, with the Levites set apart as substitutes for the firstborn. You read the blessing that God told Aaron to speak over his people, and Psalm 90, Moses' prayer about the brevity of life and the eternity of God.

You followed Israel as it left Sinai with the cloud above and the ark in front, and you saw the march break down in complaining. You read the story of the twelve spies and the decision of the people not to enter the land, and the sentence of forty years. You prayed Psalm 95 and heard its warning, "Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts." You read of Korah's rebellion, Aaron's budding staff, and the red heifer, and of Moses' sin at the rock and the bronze serpent that healed those who looked. You heard the oracles of Balaam and the promise of a star from Jacob.

You read of the second generation. They fell at Baal of Peor, were numbered again, and received Joshua as their leader. You read the offerings and the vows, the war against Midian, the stages of the journey, the boundaries of the land, and the cities of refuge, whose manslayers were freed by the death of the high priest.

Then Moses began to preach. He looked back at the journey and told the people that God had carried them as a man carries his son. He restated the Ten Commandments and gave the Shema, the greatest commandment. He told Israel that God's choice was not because of their righteousness, and he retold the golden calf. You paused to study the three offices of Christ as prophet, priest, and king. You read the law of the king and the promise of a prophet like Moses. You read the many laws of justice and mercy, the creed of the firstfruits, the covenant at Ebal and Gerizim, and the blessings and curses. Moses called Israel to choose life, taught them the Song of the Rock, blessed the tribes, and died on Mount Nebo. All along, you prayed through Psalm 78, which told the story as a lesson for children, and Psalm 119, which praised the word of God.

The unit taught that unbelief is the root of rebellion, that God is patient and faithful, that the heart must be changed by God, and that the whole of the law is to be summed up in love.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does Israel's wilderness rebellion reveal about the human heart?

Look back at the spies (Numbers 13 and 14), Korah (Numbers 16), and Psalm 95. Consider what Moses says in Deuteronomy 29:4 about the heart. Ask what Israel needed that miracles could not give.

What is the structure of Deuteronomy, and why does it matter that it resembles a covenant treaty?

Recall the pattern: a historical review (chapters 1 to 4), the commandments (5 to 26), the blessings and curses (27 to 30), and the arrangements for the future (31 to 34). Think about why God would bind his people with a covenant instead of only commanding.

What does Moses mean by the blessings and curses in Deuteronomy 27 and 28?

Review Deuteronomy 28:1-14 and 28:15-68, and the reason in 28:47. Read Galatians 3:10-14, and consider how the curses were fulfilled in Israel's history and in Christ.

How does Moses function as a type of Christ, and where does he fall short?

Think about Moses as prophet, mediator, intercessor, and leader. Consider Numbers 20, Deuteronomy 18:15, and Deuteronomy 34:10. Read Hebrews 3:1-6 and ask what the Son does that the servant could not.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for carrying you through these years of wilderness and patience.

Thank him for Christ as prophet, priest, and king.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 8 · DAYS 200-234

Conquest and Settlement

Joshua, Judges, Ruth

God brings his people into rest, partial, fragile, and pointing forward.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"But as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD."

JOSHUA 24:15

God's victories and keeping in the land (Psalms 114, 46, 76), with prayers of trust and repentance (16, 23, 130).

UNIT 8

In this unit

WEEK 29

200	Joshua 1:1-2:24	*Reading*
201	Joshua 3:1-5:15	*Reading*
202	Psalm 114	*Psalm*
203	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 30

204	Psalm 66:1-12	*Psalm*
205	Joshua 6:1-8:35	*Reading*
206	Joshua 9:1-10:43	*Reading*
207	Joshua 11:1-12:24	*Reading*
208	Joshua 13:1-17:18	*Reading*
209	Psalm 16	*Psalm*
210	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 31

211	Psalm 23	*Psalm*
212	Joshua 18:1-19:51	*Reading*
213	Joshua 20:1-22:34	*Reading*
214	Joshua 23:1-24:33	*Reading*
215	Judges 1:1-3:31	*Reading*
216	Judges 4:1-5:31	*Reading*
217	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 32

218	Psalm 46	*Psalm*
219	Psalm 76	*Psalm*
220	Judges 6:1-8:35	*Reading*
221	Judges 9:1-10:18	*Reading*

222	Judges 11:1-12:15	*Reading*
223	Judges 13:1-14:20	*Reading*
224	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 33

225	Judges 15:1-16:31	*Reading*
226	Psalm 130	*Psalm*
227	Psalm 40:1-10	*Psalm*
228	Judges 17:1-18:31	*Reading*
229	Judges 19:1-21:25	*Reading*
230	Ruth 1:1-2:23	*Reading*
231	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 34

232	Ruth 3:1-4:22	*Reading*
233	Psalm 127; Psalm 128	*Psalm*
234	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 200 · WEEK 29

Joshua 1:1-2:24

Joshua commissioned; Rahab and the spies, faith and the scarlet cord

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 1:1-2:24. Moses is dead, and the people stand on the east bank of the Jordan. Read chapter 1 as a commissioning and chapter 2 as a story about two very different kinds of faith: the nation's leader gathering courage, and a pagan prostitute in Jericho staking her life on a God she has only heard about.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Last week you closed the wilderness books with Moses' death on Mount Nebo. The man who led Israel out of Egypt and received the law at Sinai will not enter the land. Now a new leader steps forward. Joshua has been Moses' assistant since the early days of the exodus, and he was one of the two spies who trusted God at Kadesh, forty years ago. Israel now stands where their parents stood, at the edge of the promised land. Will this generation believe God where the last one did not? The book of Joshua tells how God keeps the promise he swore to Abraham, and it begins with one command repeated again and again: be strong and courageous.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God speaks to Joshua directly after Moses' death: "Moses my servant is dead. Now therefore arise, go over this Jordan" (1:2).
2. The promise is stated in the widest terms, from the wilderness to Lebanon and from the Euphrates to the Great Sea (1:4).
3. God promises, "Just as I was with Moses, so I will be with you. I will not leave you or forsake you" (1:5).

4. The command to be “strong and courageous” appears three times in the opening verses (1:6, 7, 9).
5. Success is tied to meditating on the Book of the Law “day and night” and doing what is written in it (1:8).
6. Joshua sends two spies secretly from Shittim, and they lodge with Rahab the prostitute (2:1).
7. Rahab confesses, “The LORD your God, he is God in the heavens above and on the earth beneath” (2:11).
8. She asks for kindness, and the spies promise protection if she ties a scarlet cord in her window (2:12-21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book opens with God’s word to Joshua, and the first thing it does is link the future to the past. “Moses my servant is dead.” The leader has changed, but the promise has not. God does not say, “I will be with you if you prove yourself.” He says, “Just as I was with Moses, I will be with you.” Joshua’s strength will not come from his résumé but from the presence of God. This is why the command to be courageous keeps coming back. Courage in the Bible is never self-confidence. It is the confidence of someone who has been promised that God goes with him.

Notice what makes Joshua strong. It is not a battle plan. It is the book of the law. “This Book of the Law shall not depart from your mouth, but you shall meditate on it day and night.” Joshua is told that success, in the sense of walking wisely and faithfully, comes through Scripture. This is the same pattern as Psalm 1, which you will read soon. The leader of God’s people is first a man under God’s word. The people’s response in the rest of chapter 1 is also striking. They pledge to obey Joshua just as they obeyed Moses, but they add a condition that matters: “Only may the LORD your God be with you, as he was with Moses.” They know that the authority of the leader depends on the presence of God.

Chapter 2 shifts to a very different scene. Joshua sends spies, but the story is not about the spies. It is about a woman in Jericho. Rahab is a Canaanite, a prostitute, and a citizen of a city under God’s judgment. She has no place in the covenant, no history of worship, and no reason to expect mercy. But she has heard what God did at the Red Sea and to the kings east of the Jordan, and she draws a conclusion: “The LORD your God, he is God in the heavens above and on the earth beneath.” It is one of the great confessions of the Old Testament, and it comes from the mouth of someone the reader would never expect.

She acts on that confession at great risk. She hides the spies, misleads the king's men, and negotiates for the safety of her family. Whatever one concludes about her deception, the text's focus is her faith, and the New Testament will praise it directly. Hebrews 11:31 says, "By faith Rahab the prostitute did not perish with those who were disobedient." James 2:25 holds her up as an example of faith that shows itself in works. She is not saved by her works. She is saved because she believed, and her works show it.

The scarlet cord is a quiet image of rescue. Like the blood on the doorposts of the Passover, a visible sign marks the house that will be spared when judgment comes. Christians have long seen in it a picture of the blood of Christ, and even if the text does not say so explicitly, the pattern is clear: judgment will fall on Jericho, and those who take refuge in the way God has provided will be saved. Rahab will become part of Israel. Matthew 1:5 names her in the genealogy of Jesus. A Canaanite prostitute is an ancestor of the Messiah.

STEP 5

Connection

The commissioning of Joshua echoes the commissioning of Moses at the burning bush (Exodus 3) and the promise of presence in Deuteronomy 31:6-8. The call to meditate on the law anticipates Psalm 1. Rahab's confession is the Old Testament's counterpart to the Gentile faith of the centurion (Matthew 8) and the Canaanite woman (Matthew 15). The scarlet cord recalls the Passover blood in Exodus 12. Rahab is named in Matthew 1:5, Hebrews 11:31, and James 2:25.

STEP 6

Application

First, take courage from the grounds of Joshua's courage. God does not tell you to be brave because you are capable. He tells you to be brave because he is with you. Think of one situation this week where you feel inadequate, and pray Joshua 1:9 over it.

Second, notice the link between courage and Scripture. If you want to be steady in a shaky season, ask what place God's word has in your days. What is it shaping in you right now?

Third, let Rahab reshape your idea of who God saves. If you are tempted to think some people are too far gone, remember that God rescued a prostitute from Jericho and put her in the line of Christ. And if you are the one who feels too far gone, she is your encouragement.

Fourth, think about what you have heard of God's works and how you have responded. Rahab acted on what she heard. What does your life show you believe about him?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God about a situation where you feel inadequate, and pray Joshua 1:9 over it.
- Ask him to keep his word on your lips and in your mind.
- Thank him that he saves those who seem too far gone, as he did Rahab.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 29

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

JOSHUA 1:9

DAY 201 · WEEK 29

Joshua 3:1-5:15

Crossing the Jordan; circumcision renewed; the Passover kept

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 55 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 3:1-5:15. It is a long reading, but the three chapters tell one story: the nation crosses the Jordan, builds a memorial, is renewed in covenant signs, and meets the commander of the LORD's army. Notice how often the ark, the stones, and the Passover remind Israel what God has done.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The spies have returned from Jericho with good news: the inhabitants are melting in fear. But there is still a river between Israel and the land, and in the spring it is at flood stage. Forty years earlier, God parted the Red Sea for their parents. Now he will do something similar for the children, but it will happen in a different way. The priests carrying the ark will step into the water first. Once across, Israel will pause at Gilgal for three acts that prepare them for the conquest: they will set up a memorial, renew circumcision, and keep the Passover. Only then will the commander of the LORD's army appear. The order matters. Israel is not ready to fight until they are ready to worship.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The people are told to follow the ark at a distance of about two thousand cubits, so everyone can see where it goes (3:3-4).
2. Joshua tells them, "Consecrate yourselves, for tomorrow the LORD will do wonders among you" (3:5).
3. The waters stop only when the priests' feet touch the edge of the Jordan, even though it is overflowing its banks (3:13-15).

4. The priests stand firm in the middle of the dry riverbed until all Israel has crossed (3:17).
5. Twelve stones are taken from the Jordan to Gilgal, as a memorial "so that all the peoples of the earth may know that the hand of the LORD is mighty" (4:20-24).
6. The generation born in the wilderness had not been circumcised, so Joshua circumcises them at Gilgal (5:2-7).
7. The manna ceases the day after they eat the produce of the land (5:12).
8. Joshua meets a man with a drawn sword who says he is "commander of the army of the LORD" and tells Joshua to remove his sandals, because the place is holy (5:13-15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The crossing of the Jordan deliberately echoes the crossing of the Red Sea. The author wants us to see that the God who brought Israel out of Egypt is the same God who now brings them in. But there are differences. At the Red Sea, Moses stretched out a staff and the waters parted, and Israel crossed while the enemy chased them. At the Jordan, no enemy pursues. The challenge is not escape but entry. And the miracle begins only when the priests step in. They have to walk into a flooded river before the water stops. Faith precedes sight. God does not part the waters in advance. He asks his people to take a step of trust, and then he acts.

The ark is the center of the story. It is the symbol of God's throne and presence, and it goes first. The people follow at a distance, which keeps the focus on the ark and not on the carriers. This is the pattern of the whole conquest: Israel does not win because of its army but because God goes before them. The lesson for every believer is simple. We do not go anywhere that God has not first gone.

Then the people build a memorial. Twelve stones, one for each tribe, are taken from the middle of the Jordan and piled up at Gilgal. The purpose is explained twice: so that future children will ask, "What do these stones mean?" and the parents will tell them the story. God's people are a remembering people. Spiritual memory does not happen automatically. It needs signs, stories, and rituals that pass faith from one generation to the next. This is the logic of baptism and the Lord's Supper, and it is the reason your own daily reading matters.

Chapter 5 is surprising. Israel has crossed the river, and the Canaanite kings are afraid, yet Joshua stops to circumcise every man. It seems like a terrible time to put the army out of action. But God is teaching a priority. The sign of the Abrahamic covenant had been neglected in the wilderness. Before the people take the land, they must renew the mark that

says they belong to God. Then they celebrate Passover and eat the produce of the land. The manna stops. God has provided what they need in the wilderness, and now he provides from the inheritance he promised.

Finally, a mysterious figure appears. Joshua, a warrior, asks whether he is for Israel or for their enemies. The answer is "No." The commander of the LORD's army has not come to take sides. He has come to take command. Joshua falls on his face and removes his sandals, just as Moses did at the burning bush. The figure is likely a pre-incarnate appearance of the Son, the one who leads God's armies. Joshua is not the real captain of the host. The real captain has arrived.

STEP 5

Connection

The crossing of the Jordan echoes the crossing of the Red Sea (Exodus 14) and anticipates Elijah and Elisha crossing the same river (2 Kings 2) and the baptism of Jesus there (Matthew 3). The memorial stones recall Deuteronomy 6:20-25. Circumcision renews the sign of Genesis 17. The manna's end ties to Exodus 16. The commander's command to remove sandals repeats Exodus 3:5, and the same figure appears as the "angel of the LORD" throughout the Old Testament.

STEP 6

Application

First, think about what step of faith God may be asking you to take before he shows you the outcome. The priests had to get their feet wet. Ask the Lord for the courage to take one step this week.

Second, build your own memorial. Write down three things God has done for you in the last year, and put the list somewhere you will see it. Tell someone younger in the faith about one of them.

Third, ask yourself what must be set right before you can move forward. Israel could not conquer until the covenant sign was renewed. Is there something in your relationship with God that has been neglected?

Fourth, notice that the commander is not on your side. He is in charge. Bow to him in prayer this week and ask him what he wants, rather than asking him to bless your plans.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to teach you to follow where he leads.

Thank him for what he has done, and ask him to help you tell the story to someone else.

Tell him about a “Jordan” you are facing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 29

“Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go.”

JOSHUA 1:9

DAY 202 · WEEK 29

Psalm 114

When Israel went out of Egypt, the Jordan fled

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 114 aloud. It is only eight verses long, and it is one of the most compressed poems in the Psalter. It looks back at the exodus and the crossing of the Jordan and sees the whole creation reacting to the presence of God. Read it as a celebration of the two crossings you have been reading about.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 114 is one of the Hallel psalms, sung at Passover. It may have been sung in the temple long after the days of Joshua, as Israel remembered how God brought them out of Egypt and into the land. It pairs two events you have just read about: the splitting of the Red Sea and the stopping of the Jordan. The psalm treats them as one great act of deliverance. Its poetry is bold and playful. It does not explain how the miracles happened. It simply asks: what could make the sea flee, the river turn back, and the mountains skip like rams? The answer is the presence of God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm begins with the exodus: “When Israel went out from Egypt, the house of Jacob from a people of strange language” (v. 1).
2. Judah became God’s “sanctuary” and Israel his “dominion” (v. 2). The people are his dwelling place.
3. “The sea looked and fled; Jordan turned back” (v. 3). The two crossings are placed side by side.
4. The mountains “skipped like rams” and the hills “like lambs” (v. 4).

5. The psalm asks the sea and river, “What ails you?” (v. 5), as though they were nervous children.
6. The answer is direct: “Tremble, O earth, at the presence of the Lord” (v. 7).
7. The God of Jacob turns rock into “a pool of water” and flint into “a spring of water” (v. 8).
8. The name of God is withheld until verse 7, which heightens the effect.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 114 is a poem about reaction. The first four verses describe what happened in nature when God moved. The sea saw and ran away. The Jordan flowed backward. The mountains leaped. These are not scientific descriptions. They are the poet’s way of showing that creation itself recognizes its Lord. Water, which can drown an army, is no more than a servant. Mountains, which seem immovable, jump like frightened lambs. If the natural world responds this way to the presence of God, how should we?

Then the poet does something delightful. He turns and interrogates the sea and the river. “What ails you, O sea, that you flee?” It is almost comical. The mighty Red Sea and the flooding Jordan, scolded as though they had panicked for no reason. The answer comes in verse 7: “Tremble, O earth, at the presence of the Lord, at the presence of the God of Jacob.” The poet has delayed the name of God until this point. For six verses we do not know who made the sea flee. When the name arrives, it carries weight: the Lord, the God of Jacob. This is the God who attached himself to a deceiver and made him Israel. The power that shakes the earth is the same power that is committed to a covenant family.

The last verse is the most surprising. After all the shaking and fleeing, the poem closes with a small, tender image: the God who turns rock into a pool of water. This points back to the water from the rock at Meribah, and to God’s care for his thirsty people in the wilderness. The God who makes mountains skip is also the God who provides a drink for his people. His power and his provision are the same.

For Christians, the psalm tells a bigger story. Israel’s exodus and entry are a pattern. Christ passes through the waters of death and brings his people to an inheritance. Paul says in 1 Corinthians 10:4 that the rock in the wilderness was Christ, and in Hebrews, the land is a shadow of the rest to come. Christian baptism is also described as a crossing: we pass through water out of slavery and into a new life.

STEP 5

Connection

The psalm draws on Exodus 14-15 (the sea), Joshua 3-4 (the Jordan), and Exodus 17 and Numbers 20 (the water from the rock). It belongs to the Hallel, Psalms 113-118, sung at Passover, and so Jesus and his disciples likely sang it at the Last Supper (Matthew 26:30). Paul interprets the rock as Christ in 1 Corinthians 10:1-4.

STEP 6

Application

Let this psalm reorder your sense of scale. The things that loom large in your life, such as deadlines, diagnoses, or conflicts, are like the Red Sea and the Jordan. They look immovable until God shows up. Name one thing you are facing, and tell it, in prayer, that it is small compared to the presence of the Lord.

Notice also the God of Jacob. If God attached himself to someone like Jacob, he can bind himself to you. His power is not set against your weakness. It is committed to your good.

Finally, take a drink. When you are thirsty spiritually, remember the rock and the pool. Christ is the source. Come to him and drink.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tremble before the God who turns back seas and rivers, in your own words.

Ask him to turn the hard places in your life into springs of water.

Thank him that he is bound to his people by covenant.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 29

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

JOSHUA 1:9

DAY 203 · WEEK 29

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you finished the wilderness books with the review of Unit 7, and you crossed the Jordan with Joshua. Take a quiet moment today to sit with the opening of Joshua. Read Joshua 1:1-9 again slowly if you can, and let the promise of God's presence settle in.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

JOSHUA 1:9

REST

Meditation

Joshua 1:9 is a command wrapped around a promise, and the promise is what holds the command up.

"Have I not commanded you?" God begins with a reminder. He has already spoken. Joshua does not need a new word. He needs to believe the one he has.

"Be strong and courageous." This is the third time in nine verses that the words appear. Courage is not a feeling that arrives on its own. It is a choice made in response to what God has said. Joshua will be afraid. God does not deny it. He commands courage because fear is real.

“Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed.” The two words describe fear that shakes you from the inside and discouragement that drains you from outside. Both are answered by the same thing.

“For the LORD your God is with you wherever you go.” This is the reason. Not “because you are strong,” not “because you are well prepared,” but because he is with you. Every step into unknown territory is accompanied.

Notice the last phrase: wherever you go. Joshua would go into the Jordan, into Jericho, into battle, and into long years of leadership. The promise follows him into all of it. And for the Christian, the promise is stronger still. Jesus said, “I am with you always, to the end of the age” (Matthew 28:20). Carry this verse into the places you dread this week.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the wilderness books with the Unit 7 review, spending time in Psalm 119, the long song of delight in God’s word. Then you began Unit 8 and the book of Joshua. You heard God commission a new leader and promise his presence. You met Rahab, the Canaanite woman who confessed that the LORD is God in heaven above and on earth beneath, and who hung a scarlet cord in her window. You watched the priests step into a flooded Jordan and saw the waters stop, you saw twelve stones piled up at Gilgal, and you saw a new generation circumcised and the Passover kept. You met the commander of the LORD’s army, and you sang Psalm 114, in which the sea flees and the mountains skip.

The week taught one lesson in many forms: God keeps his promises, and he goes before his people.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where do you most need courage right now? Joshua was not told to feel brave. He was told to be strong because God was with him. Name one situation where fear or discouragement is pressing on you, and write down what it would look like to take one faithful step in it this week.

How does Rahab’s story point you to Christ? She was an outsider under judgment, who heard about God’s works, believed, and took refuge in the way of rescue he provided. A scarlet cord marked her house, and she was brought into God’s people and into the line of the Messiah. How does her story clarify what it means that Jesus saves, not on the basis of who we are, but on the basis of what he has done?

What “memorial stones” help you remember what God has done? Think about the practices, places, or people that keep your faith anchored. Is there one you have neglected? What could you do this week to retell God’s faithfulness to someone else?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Rest in God’s promise to be with you wherever you go.

Thank him for Rahab, and for mercy that reaches outsiders like you.

Tell him what you are leaving in his hands this Sabbath.

DAY 204 · WEEK 30

Psalm 66:1-12

Make a joyful noise; God tested us

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 66:1-12. You read the opening verses of this psalm in Unit 3. Today you read further, to the part where the psalmist remembers the times God tested his people. Notice how the praise turns from the whole earth to the experience of Israel, and how God's discipline is described as both fire and a spacious place.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This week begins with a psalm of praise that moves from the global to the personal. The psalmist first calls the whole earth to shout to God, and then recalls the exodus and the crossing of the sea, and finally speaks about the nation's hard experiences. It fits the story of Joshua well. Israel has crossed the Jordan and stands on the edge of a conquest that will test them. The psalm reminds us that God's tests are not meant to destroy but to refine, and that they lead to a place of abundance. It is a good psalm to read as you prepare for the walls of Jericho.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens, "Shout for joy to God, all the earth" (v. 1), and calls people to sing the glory of his name.
2. "Say to God, How awesome are your deeds!" (v. 3). Even enemies cringe before his power.
3. "He turned the sea into dry land; they passed through the river on foot" (v. 6). Both crossings are recalled.
4. "He rules by his might forever, his eyes keep watch on the nations" (v. 7).
5. God "has kept us among the living and has not let our feet slip" (v. 9).

6. “For you, O God, have tested us; you have tried us as silver is tried” (v. 10).
7. The imagery of hardship is vivid: nets, burdens on the back, men riding over heads, fire and water (vv. 11-12).
8. The psalm ends this section with “yet you have brought us out to a place of abundance” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 66 reminds us that praise and hardship belong together. The psalmist does not say that life has been easy. He says that God has tested his people the way a refiner tests silver, and that the testing was real. Israel went into the net. They felt a heavy weight on their backs. They felt men trample them, and they walked through fire and flood. The psalm does not shrink from describing the pain. And yet it begins with a shout of joy.

What allows the psalmist to praise God in the middle of hardship? The answer is in the sequence. Verses 5-7 remind the people of the God who turned the sea into dry land. Verse 8 says he “has kept us among the living.” The pain was real, but so was God’s presence in it. Every hardship has a boundary that God has set. The fire and water do not overwhelm. They are the way to a place of abundance.

The word “tested” is important. In the Bible, God does not test people to find out something he does not know. He tests to reveal and to refine. A silversmith heats the metal to burn off the dross and leave pure silver. In the same way, God allows pressure so that what is false in our faith will fall away and what is true will remain. This is the same logic you will see in Joshua. The conquest is not only a military campaign but a test of whether Israel will trust God’s word and keep his covenant. Some of the hardest tests will come after the greatest victories.

The final phrase, “a place of abundance,” lifts the eyes. Hardship is not the end of the story. It is a corridor. The God who brings his people through fire and water brings them out into a spacious place. For the Christian, this finds its fullest sense in Christ, who passed through the waters of death, the “fire” of God’s judgment, and rose to the abundance of new life. His people follow him through the same journey, and the end is not loss but fullness.

STEP 5

Connection

The first seven verses recall the exodus (Exodus 14-15) and the Jordan crossing (Joshua 3). The image of refining silver appears in Proverbs 17:3, Zechariah 13:9, and 1 Peter 1:6-7. Isaiah 43:2 promises that God will be with his people through water and fire. The “place of abundance” anticipates the land of promise and the new creation in Revelation 21.

STEP 6

Application

When you face hardship, avoid the two easy conclusions that God has abandoned you or that you have failed some test. Instead, ask what he might be refining. Take ten minutes today to name one area where you have felt pressure, and pray: “Lord, what do you want to burn away, and what do you want to keep?”

Also, practice praising God before the pressure lifts. The psalmist begins with a shout. Choose one song or psalm and sing or read it aloud today, even if your circumstances have not changed.

Finally, remind yourself of the place of abundance. Hardship in Christ is never wasted.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for testing you and keeping you among the living.
- Tell him what pressure you are under and trust him in it.
- Ask him to burn away what does not belong in you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 30

“The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance.”

PSALM 16:5-6

DAY 205 · WEEK 30

Joshua 6:1-8:35

Jericho falls; Achan's sin; Ai taken

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 6:1-8:35. These chapters contain some of the best-known stories in the Old Testament and some of the most uncomfortable. Read slowly through the fall of Jericho, then through Achan's sin and Israel's humiliating defeat at Ai, and finally through the renewal of the covenant on Mount Ebal. Ask throughout: what does this show about God's holiness, and about the seriousness of sin?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has crossed the Jordan, and the first fortified city stands in the way. Jericho is the gateway to the land. God does not give Joshua a battle plan in the usual sense. He gives him a worship procession. For six days, the army will march around the walls with the ark and seven priests blowing rams' horns, and on the seventh day they will march seven times and shout. Victory is God's gift. But right after the high of Jericho comes the low of Ai. A single man's sin brings defeat on the whole community. These chapters teach that God's people are called to trust his power and to take his holiness seriously.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The LORD says to Joshua, "See, I have given Jericho into your hand" (6:2). The victory is announced before the battle.
2. The army marches around the city for six days in silence, and on the seventh day shouts as the walls fall (6:3-20).
3. Everything in Jericho is placed under the ban (herem) and devoted to the LORD, except Rahab and her family, who are spared (6:17-25).

4. Achan takes a robe from Shinar, silver, and a bar of gold from the devoted things and hides them in his tent (7:1, 21).
5. Israel is routed at Ai, and thirty-six men die. Joshua tears his clothes and falls on his face (7:4-6).
6. The LORD says, "Israel has sinned; they have transgressed my covenant" (7:11). The community is treated as a unit.
7. Achan is identified by lot, confesses, and is judged along with his family (7:16-26).
8. After the victory at Ai, Joshua builds an altar on Mount Ebal and reads the blessings and curses of the law to the whole assembly (8:30-35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The fall of Jericho is a story about who wins battles. No siege equipment, no tactics, no armies are needed. God hands over the city to a people who march, worship, and shout. The point is made so clearly that nobody can miss it: the walls fall by faith. Hebrews 11:30 summarizes it, "By faith the walls of Jericho fell down after they had been encircled for seven days." The first victory in the land belongs entirely to God. It is also the first fruits of the conquest, and everything in the city is devoted to the LORD.

This is the difficult theme of herem, the ban. Everything in Jericho was to be destroyed. Modern readers rightly feel the weight of this. How can we read it? First, the Bible presents this as a specific, unrepeatable act of divine judgment on a people whose sin had reached its full measure. Genesis 15:16 says that the iniquity of the Amorites was not yet complete in Abraham's day, which means God waited four hundred years before bringing judgment. Deuteronomy 9:4 says it was "because of the wickedness of these nations" that God drove them out, and warns Israel not to think they are being given the land because of their own righteousness. Second, Jericho is judged and Rahab is saved. The conquest does not teach that Israel is better than its neighbors. It teaches that God is holy, that sin is judged, and that the only safety is to take refuge in him. Third, the command is narrowly bound to the original conquest. The New Testament never uses it as a model for the church. Our weapons are not carnal (2 Corinthians 10:4).

Then chapter 7 shows that this holiness cuts both ways. Achan, an Israelite, takes some of the devoted things. His sin is hidden, but not from God. Israel loses at Ai and thirty-six men die. God's explanation is frightening: "Israel has sinned." The community is bound together, and one man's secret disobedience damages everyone. The text carefully traces Achan's sin in the verbs of Genesis 3: "I saw... I coveted... I took... I hid" (7:21). He is a second Adam in a garden of promise, and his sin brings death.

Joshua's response is instructive. He falls on his face, and God tells him to stand up and deal with the sin. Prayer without repentance is not enough. Achan's judgment is severe, and the valley where it happens is named Achor, meaning "trouble." But the prophets will later turn the name around. Hosea 2:15 promises that God will make the Valley of Achor "a door of hope." God's holiness is not the last word.

The section ends not with a battle but with a covenant renewal. On Mount Ebal and Mount Gerizim, Joshua reads the entire law, blessings and curses, to the people as Moses commanded. The conquest is a covenant event. Israel is not simply taking territory. They are living under the word of the LORD.

STEP 5

Connection

The collapse of Jericho is recalled in Hebrews 11:30. Rahab's rescue ties back to Joshua 2 and forward to Matthew 1:5. The ban's justification is in Genesis 15:16 and Deuteronomy 9:4-5 and 20:16-18. Achan's sin echoes Genesis 3:6 and anticipates Ananias and Sapphira in Acts 5. The Valley of Achor reappears in Isaiah 65:10 and Hosea 2:15. The covenant ceremony on Ebal fulfills Deuteronomy 11:29 and 27:1-26.

STEP 6

Application

First, ask what your "walls" might be. Where are you trying to win by effort when God asks you to trust and obey? Take one concrete step of worshipful obedience this week, and leave the outcome with him.

Second, take Achan's story as a warning about hidden sin. No sin is private. Is there something you are concealing, perhaps a habit, a debt, a relationship, or a resentment? Bring it into the light, first to God, and then to a trusted friend. Concealment is how small sins grow.

Third, remember that Christ is our Joshua. His name is the same in Hebrew. He defeats the powers we cannot overcome, and he is also the one who bore the curse of our sin. Hosea's "door of hope" is a picture of what he does with our trouble.

Finally, hold both God's holiness and mercy together. Rahab's rescue and Achan's judgment are on the same pages. Both teach us to fear and love him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to show you any hidden sin and to give you courage to confess it.

Thank him for the victory he gives.

Thank him for turning a valley of trouble into a door of hope.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 30

"The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance."

PSALM 16:5-6

DAY 206 · WEEK 30

Joshua 9:1-10:43

The Gibeonite deception; the southern campaign

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 70 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 9:1-10:43. The first chapter is a story about deception and a hasty oath. The second is a story about a great victory in which God fights from heaven. Notice how the two are connected: the treaty with Gibeon is what pulls Israel into the southern campaign.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After Ai, news of Israel's victories has spread across the land. The kings of the hill country gather in an alliance to fight Joshua. But one group has another plan. The Gibeonites, a Hivite people living only a few miles away, decide to trick Israel into a peace treaty by pretending to come from a distant country. They put on worn-out clothing and carry moldy bread. Joshua and the leaders fall for it, and make a covenant with them without asking the LORD. The consequences of that oath will shape Israel's history for centuries. Yet God uses even Israel's mistake to bring about a remarkable day.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The Gibeonites disguise themselves with old sacks, worn wineskins, patched sandals, and dry, moldy bread (9:4-5).
2. The Israelites "took some of their provisions, but did not ask counsel from the LORD" (9:14).
3. Joshua makes peace with them and the leaders swear an oath (9:15).
4. Three days later the deception is discovered, but the leaders refuse to break the oath: "We have sworn to them by the LORD, the God of Israel" (9:18-19).
5. The Gibeonites are made woodcutters and water carriers for the house of God (9:21-27).

6. Five Amorite kings attack Gibeon, and Joshua marches all night to rescue them (10:5-9).
7. The LORD threw large hailstones from heaven, and more died from the hailstones than the Israelites killed with the sword (10:11).
8. Joshua says, "Sun, stand still at Gibeon," and the text records, "There has been no day like it before or since, when the LORD heeded the voice of a man" (10:12-14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Gibeonite story is a lesson in discernment. Israel has just seen God defeat Jericho and Ai, and they might be tempted to feel that they can handle anything. But the text records a single sentence that explains the problem: "they did not ask counsel from the LORD." They looked at the bread, they sampled the supplies, and they trusted their own judgment. It was a reasonable-looking decision made without prayer. The lesson for believers is not that every decision needs a miracle, but that confidence in our own wisdom is dangerous. The people who were sure of themselves were fooled by a few moldy crusts.

The oath they swore becomes binding. Even when the leaders realize they have been deceived, they keep their word. This is a remarkable testimony to the seriousness of vows made in God's name. Psalm 15:4 describes the person who "swears to his own hurt and does not change." The Gibeonites are spared, but made servants at the sanctuary. Surprisingly, this turns out for their good. They are brought into the worship of Israel's God, just as Rahab was. Gibeon would later become a city of the Levites and the site of the tabernacle in Solomon's time. Out of a deception, God brought mercy.

Chapter 10 shows Israel's loyalty to a vow. When the five kings attack Gibeon, Joshua could have left the Gibeonites to their fate. They had lied to him. But the oath binds him, so he marches all night. And God honors the faithfulness. The LORD throws hailstones, and the sun and moon pause. Whatever one concludes about the exact nature of this event, the author's point is plain: this was the LORD fighting for Israel. "There has been no day like it before or since, when the LORD heeded the voice of a man." The statement is stunning. God listens to the prayer of a man. He is not a distant sovereign who ignores his people. He bends to the requests of those who walk in faithfulness.

The chapter also continues the theme of divine warfare. The five kings are brought out, and Joshua has his commanders put their feet on their necks. It is a symbolic act of total victory, and it is an acted parable. The enemies of God's people will be subdued, and the people share in the victory of their leader. This image will be used again in the New Testament. In Romans 16:20, Paul promises that "the God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet." The conquest looks forward to a greater victory.

STEP 5

Connection

Joshua's failure to ask counsel echoes Numbers 27:21, where Joshua was to consult the LORD through Eleazar. The sanctity of oaths is addressed in Numbers 30 and Psalm 15:4. The Gibeonites' later history appears in 2 Samuel 21:1-9 and 1 Kings 3:4. The hailstones recall the plagues in Exodus 9, and the sun standing still is echoed in Habakkuk 3:11. The feet on the necks of the kings anticipates Psalm 110:1 and 1 Corinthians 15:25.

STEP 6

Application

Make a habit of asking God before you decide. Not only for the big choices, but for the ordinary ones: a commitment, a purchase, a relationship, a job offer. Pause and pray before you say yes. Ask a wise believer to help you see what you might be missing.

Second, take seriously the words you promise. When you give your word, keep it, even when it costs you. A reputation for faithfulness is a witness to the God who keeps his word.

Third, take encouragement from the day the sun stood still. God listens to the prayers of his people. Bring him something that seems too big to ask.

Fourth, see Christ in this story. He saves us when we come to him with nothing, and he brings the deceived and the outsiders near, as he did with Gibeon.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess where you trust your own judgment without asking God's.

Ask him to teach you to seek his counsel first and to be someone whose word can be trusted.

Thank him that he fights for his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 30

“The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance.”

PSALM 16:5-6

DAY 207 · WEEK 30

Joshua 11:1-12:24

The northern campaign; the defeated kings

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 11:1-12:24. Chapter 11 tells of the northern campaign and the summary of Joshua's victories. Chapter 12 is a list of defeated kings, which may seem dry. Read it as a record of God's faithfulness. Pay attention to the repeated phrase "as the LORD had commanded Moses."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The southern campaign is complete. Now, in the north, a larger coalition gathers under Jabin, king of Hazor, with a massive army, "as many as the sand on the seashore," along with horses and chariots. For Israelite infantry, chariots were the most terrifying weapon of the age. The odds look impossible. Yet God speaks to Joshua with the same words he has used before: "Do not be afraid of them." The chapter then steps back and offers a summary of the war and a list of the kings defeated on both sides of the Jordan. It reads like a ledger, and in a sense it is: a record of what God did in fulfillment of what he promised.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Jabin of Hazor gathers a coalition of northern kings with a huge army, horses, and chariots (11:1-5).
2. The LORD tells Joshua, "Do not be afraid of them, for tomorrow at this time I will give over all of them" (11:6).
3. Joshua is told to hamstring the horses and burn the chariots with fire (11:6, 9).
4. Hazor, "formerly the head of all those kingdoms," is burned (11:10-11).
5. "Joshua did to them just as the LORD said to him" (11:9), and "as the LORD had commanded Moses his servant, so Moses commanded Joshua" (11:15).

6. “There was not a city that made peace with the people of Israel except the Hivites of Gibeon” (11:19).

7. “It was the LORD’s doing to harden their hearts that they should come against Israel in battle” (11:20).

8. Chapter 12 lists thirty-one defeated kings, beginning with the two east of the Jordan, Sihon and Og (12:1-24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The northern campaign shows the pattern of the conquest in miniature: a threat that looks impossible, a word from God, and a victory that comes through obedience. The command to hamstring the horses and burn the chariots is a notable detail. God is teaching Israel not to depend on the military technology of the nations. Psalm 20:7 will later put it this way: “Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God.” The order is a test of dependence. If Israel keeps the horses, they might start to trust them.

The chapter also reveals something about the nature of the conquest. Verse 20 says it was “the LORD’s doing to harden their hearts.” This is the same language used of Pharaoh. The nations of Canaan were not innocent bystanders who were randomly attacked. They were in rebellion, and the war was an act of judgment. God allowed their resistance to run its course. Many readers struggle with this, and the Bible doesn’t hide it. But Scripture is consistent in how it frames the matter: God judges sin, and he does so with justice. Paul takes up the same theme in Romans 9-11, where hardening and mercy sit together in God’s plan.

The repeated phrase “as the LORD commanded Moses” also deserves attention. Joshua is not an innovator. He is a faithful follower of the word of God. The victories happen because he carries out what has been commanded. The author makes it a refrain, because he wants the reader to see that Israel’s success depends not on military genius but on obedience to a word.

Chapter 12 closes the first half of the book with a list. At first it seems like a dry ledger, but it carries a quiet testimony. God remembers each defeated king. The record is a monument. It tells every generation of Israel that these were real enemies, defeated at real places, by real power. When the people doubt, they can look at the list. The God who did all this will not abandon them. And Christians read the list with a larger horizon. The enemies Christ has defeated are far greater: sin, death, and the devil. The cross and resurrection are the real Jericho, and the church is called to live in light of a victory that is already won.

STEP 5

Connection

The “hardening” language connects to Exodus 4-14 and to Romans 9:17-18. Trust in horses versus the name of the LORD appears in Psalm 20:7, 33:16-17, and Isaiah 31:1. The commands to Moses are in Deuteronomy 7 and 20. Sihon and Og were defeated in Numbers 21, which you read earlier. The theme of enemy kings defeated looks forward to Colossians 2:15, where Christ “disarmed the rulers and authorities.”

STEP 6

Application

First, ask what your chariots are. What do you rely on that is not God: a plan, a savings account, a network of influence? None of these are evil in themselves, but they may be places where trust has quietly moved. Ask the Lord what to release.

Second, make obedience a habit. Joshua succeeded because he did what he was told, even when it did not make military sense. Choose one clear command of Scripture that you have been delaying, and do it this week.

Third, keep a record. Write down a short list of the ways God has defeated something in your life: a habit, a fear, a broken relationship. Read it when you are discouraged.

Fourth, remember that Christ has won the decisive battle. Live from his victory, not toward it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you from trusting in chariots and horses, whatever those are in your life.

Ask him to teach you to obey even when his word seems strange.

Thank Christ for disarming the powers that oppose you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 30

“The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance.”

PSALM 16:5-6

DAY 208 · WEEK 30

Joshua 13:1-17:18

Tribal allotments begin, the inheritance [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 121 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 13:1-17:18. This is a long reading in the geographic style of the book, and it can feel like a list. Don't try to memorize the places. Read it for the shape: the land is being divided among the tribes, and God is distributing an inheritance. Keep your eye out for Caleb in chapter 14 and the daughters of Zelophehad in chapter 17.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The conquest is over, at least in principle, but there is still much land to be taken. Joshua is old, and God tells him to divide the territory among the tribes so that each can finish the work. The next several chapters read like a land registry. For many modern readers they are the most skippable part of the Bible. But for the first readers, they were among the most precious. This was proof that God had kept his promise to Abraham: he had given his people a place. Each border and town was a statement that this family belongs here. For us, the lists point toward a greater inheritance.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God tells Joshua, "You are old and advanced in years, and there remains yet very much land to possess" (13:1).
2. Moses had already given the eastern territory to Reuben, Gad, and half of Manasseh (13:8-33).
3. "To the tribe of Levi alone Moses gave no inheritance. The LORD God of Israel is their inheritance" (13:33).
4. Caleb, at eighty-five, asks for the hill country of Hebron and says, "Give me this hill country of which the LORD spoke on that day" (14:6-12).

5. Hebron becomes Caleb's inheritance "because he wholly followed the LORD" (14:14).
6. Judah's allotment is the longest and is described first (15:1-63), though Judah could not drive out the Jebusites in Jerusalem (15:63).
7. Ephraim and Manasseh, the sons of Joseph, receive the central hill country, and Ephraim does not drive out the Canaanites in Gezer (16:10).
8. The daughters of Zelophehad ask for and receive an inheritance among their father's brothers (17:3-6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The land lists are not an interruption of the story but its fulfillment. From Genesis 12, God had promised Abraham a land. Four hundred years of waiting, a slavery in Egypt, and forty years in the wilderness had passed. Now, tribe by tribe and family by family, the promise is distributed. God keeps his word down to the details of boundary lines. The lists are the opposite of vague spirituality. They show that God's promises have addresses.

Several details shine out. First, the Levites receive no territory because "the LORD God of Israel is their inheritance." This is one of the great lines of the Old Testament. They have cities to live in, but their portion is God himself. It is a picture of what is true for every believer. Whatever else we may have or lack, our true inheritance is the Lord. Psalm 16, which you will read soon, will express the same idea: "The LORD is my chosen portion."

Second, Caleb's request is a remarkable story of long-term faithfulness. He is eighty-five years old, and he asks for the hardest land in the region, a hill country full of giants. He does not ask for retirement. Forty-five years earlier, he and Joshua had stood against the report of the other spies. He says, "I wholly followed the LORD my God." His strength is the same at eighty-five as at forty, and he is ready for the fight. The text marks him out as a model of perseverance. His faith did not fade with age. It deepened.

Third, the daughters of Zelophehad ask for what they are due. God had already promised in Numbers 27 that daughters could inherit when there were no sons, and now they remind Joshua. The story shows God's care for the vulnerable and the importance of claiming what has been promised.

But there are also shadows. Judah cannot drive out the Jebusites. Ephraim does not drive out the Canaanites at Gezer. These small notes of incomplete obedience foreshadow the book of Judges. The land is given, but Israel must take it. Many of God's gifts work this way: the inheritance is secure, but we must live into it. Paul says the same about our salvation, "work out your own salvation… for it is God who works in you" (Philippians 2:12-13).

STEP 5

Connection

The land promise is rooted in Genesis 12:7, 15:18-21, and 17:8. The Levites' inheritance appears in Numbers 18:20 and Deuteronomy 10:9. Caleb's story begins in Numbers 13-14. The daughters of Zelophehad first appear in Numbers 27 and 36. The "inheritance" language runs into the New Testament in Ephesians 1:11-14, Colossians 1:12, and 1 Peter 1:3-4, where believers have an imperishable inheritance kept in heaven.

STEP 6

Application

First, consider your inheritance. If you are in Christ, you have been given the Spirit as a guarantee of an inheritance that cannot fade. Let that anchor your view of what you do and do not have this week.

Second, learn from Caleb. Where might you be tempted to coast in your faith? Ask the Lord for the kind of faith that still asks for the hill country at eighty-five.

Third, notice that Israel's incomplete obedience begins in small places. Is there a "Gezer" in your life, an area of compromise you have chosen not to confront? Name it and ask for help.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for keeping his promises down to the last detail.

Ask for a wholehearted faith like Caleb's.

Ask him to show you where you have left territory unclaimed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 30

"The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance."

PSALM 16:5-6

DAY 209 · WEEK 30

Psalm 16

The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 16 slowly. It is a short psalm of trust, and it ties closely to the land inheritance you read about yesterday. David uses the language of boundary lines and allotments, but he applies it to God himself. Notice the shift in the last verses to the hope of life beyond death.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 16 is a "miktam" of David, a psalm of quiet confidence. It sits well with the reading in Joshua. After surveying tribal allotments and the Levites' inheritance in the LORD himself, we find David using the same language: "The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup." The psalm also has a surprising ending. Peter quotes it on the day of Pentecost as a prophecy of the resurrection of Christ (Acts 2:25-31), and Paul does the same in Acts 13. So it is a psalm of David's own trust in God, and also a psalm that points beyond David to the Messiah.

STEP 3

Observation

1. David prays, "Preserve me, O God, for in you I take refuge" (v. 1).
2. "I have no good apart from you" (v. 2).
3. He delights in the saints in the land, "the excellent ones" (v. 3).
4. Those who choose another god multiply their sorrows (v. 4).
5. "The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot" (v. 5).
6. "The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance" (v. 6).

7. “I have set the LORD always before me; because he is at my right hand, I shall not be shaken” (v. 8).
8. “You will not abandon my soul to Sheol, or let your holy one see corruption” (v. 10).
9. “In your presence there is fullness of joy; at your right hand are pleasures forevermore” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 16 is a profession of contentment. David has examined his life, and he discovers that everything good in it comes from God. “I have no good apart from you.” That is the first big claim. He then applies the language of the land to the Lord himself: “The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot.” A “portion” is a share of an inheritance, a “cup” is what one is given to drink, and a “lot” is the allotment of land. David uses exactly the vocabulary of the chapters you just read in Joshua, and he applies it to God. God is not only the giver of the inheritance. He is the inheritance.

The effect is a settled gladness. “The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places.” It is the speech of someone who has stopped comparing his portion with others. He looks at what God has given, and he says it is beautiful. This is the opposite of covetousness. Those who run after other gods multiply their sorrows, because they chase a portion that cannot satisfy.

David also has a practice. “I have set the LORD always before me.” The posture is a conscious habit of living with God in view. And the result is stability: “Because he is at my right hand, I shall not be shaken.” A person who keeps God before his eyes finds that circumstances lose some of their power.

Then the psalm turns upward. “My flesh also dwells secure. For you will not abandon my soul to Sheol, or let your holy one see corruption.” David is confident that death will not have the last word. Peter explains in Acts 2 that David could not be speaking only of himself, for David died and his tomb is still known. He was speaking as a prophet of the resurrection of Christ, “the Holy One,” who did not see corruption. Jesus is the one for whom this psalm is perfectly true. His body was laid in a tomb, but it did not decay. And because he rose, those who are in him share the promise of verse 11: “You make known to me the path of life; in your presence there is fullness of joy; at your right hand are pleasures forevermore.”

STEP 5

Connection

The language of portion and lot draws on Numbers 18:20 and Joshua 13-19. Peter quotes verses 8-11 in Acts 2:25-28, and Paul quotes verse 10 in Acts 13:35. Psalm 73:25-26 expresses a similar delight in God as portion. The path of life recalls Proverbs 4 and Matthew 7:13-14, and

the “fullness of joy” anticipates Revelation 21:3-4.

STEP 6

Application

Test your contentment. Where are you tempted to say, “If only I had…”? Pray through Psalm 16:5-6 and ask the Lord to make you glad in the portion he has given.

Practice setting the LORD before you. Choose one moment in each day, such as your commute or your lunch break, to pause and pray, “Lord, you are here.” See whether it changes how you handle that part of the day.

And give thanks for the resurrection. Because Christ was not abandoned to the grave, your own death will not be an abandonment either.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what it means that he is your chosen portion.
- Ask him to teach you contentment in him and to keep him always before you.
- Thank him for Christ’s resurrection and the hope it gives you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 30

“The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance.”

PSALM 16:5-6

DAY 210 · WEEK 30

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you followed Israel through Jericho, Ai, Gibeon, and the northern campaign, and you read the long lists of tribal allotments. Today, rest in the one thing all these chapters point to: God himself is the inheritance of his people. If you have time, reread Psalm 16.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance."

PSALM 16:5-6

REST

Meditation

Psalm 16:5-6 takes the dry geography of this week's reading and turns it into worship.

"The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup." The Levites received no land, and the text said, "the LORD is their inheritance." David says the same of himself, and the New Testament says it of every believer. If you are in Christ, you have been given God. Not just his gifts, or his help, but himself.

"You hold my lot." A lot is something cast, and what falls is out of your hands. But David says that God holds it. Your circumstances, your family, your calling, and your seasons are not random. They are in the hand of one who loves you.

“The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places.” The boundary lines in Joshua were measured with cords. David looks at the lines of his life and calls them pleasant. This does not mean everything is easy. It means that the gift of God himself outweighs any other loss.

“Indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance.” This is a statement of gratitude. Say the verse aloud. Notice what you are tempted to compare. Then let the verse reorient you toward the one who holds you. Christ is the heir of all things, and in him you are a co-heir.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw what a faithful God does with a faithful people. You listened to the music of Psalm 66, which called you to shout for joy and recalled God’s testing. You watched Jericho fall without a siege and Israel stumble at Ai because of Achan’s hidden sin. You watched Joshua make a hasty treaty with Gibeon and see the sun stand still. You followed the northern campaign and the list of defeated kings, and then read the first of the great land allotments, with Caleb asking for his mountain at eighty-five and the daughters of Zelophehad claiming their inheritance. And you sang Psalm 16, where David calls the LORD his portion and his cup.

The week held two truths together: God is holy and judges sin, and he is also faithful and gives his people an inheritance.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where is God calling you to trust his power instead of your own resources? Jericho fell by faith and obedience, and Ai fell after sin was dealt with. Think about a situation you are tempted to handle by effort alone. What would it look like to pray first, and then obey?

How does Jesus fulfill what Joshua only began? Joshua led Israel into a land, but the land was partial and was lost. Jesus, whose name means the same thing, leads his people into a better inheritance that cannot fade. How does Hebrews 4:8-9 or Psalm 16:10-11 help you see the difference? What does it mean to you that the inheritance is secured by Christ’s resurrection?

What are you tempted to count as your portion apart from God? Money, status, comfort, relationships, or reputation can all quietly become what we live for. Name one and ask the Lord to teach you to say, “You are my portion.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is your portion and that your lines have fallen in pleasant places.

Thank Jesus, the true Joshua, for winning an inheritance you could never earn.

Rest in him today.

DAY 211 · WEEK 31

Psalm 23

The LORD is my shepherd, rest and restoration

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 23. It is probably the most familiar psalm in the Bible, so read it as if for the first time. Slow down at each line. Notice the change from third person ("he") to second person ("you") in the middle of verse 4, as the psalm moves from talking about the shepherd to talking to him.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 23 comes at the beginning of this week as a reflection on the rest God gives. Israel is settling into the land, and the shepherd imagery of this psalm captures what the land of promise is meant to be: a place of green pastures and still waters under the care of a good shepherd. David, who wrote this psalm, was himself a shepherd boy before he was a king, so he knew what a shepherd's work involved. He uses it to describe the LORD's care. This psalm is often read at funerals, but it is a psalm for the living as much as for the dying. It is about what it means to lack nothing because of who God is.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want" (v. 1).
2. He makes me lie down in green pastures and leads me beside still waters (v. 2).
3. "He restores my soul. He leads me in paths of righteousness for his name's sake" (v. 3).
4. "Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me" (v. 4).
5. The shepherd's "rod and staff" comfort me (v. 4).

6. “You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies; you anoint my head with oil; my cup overflows” (v. 5).
7. “Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life” (v. 6).
8. “I shall dwell in the house of the LORD forever” (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening line carries the whole psalm. “The LORD is my shepherd.” Everything that follows is an unpacking of what it means. “I shall not want” does not mean “I will get everything I desire.” It means “I will lack nothing I truly need, because I belong to him.” A shepherd takes responsibility for his sheep. He finds food, water, rest, and safety. Sheep can do none of this for themselves. They are among the most dependent animals, and David says that is a good thing, because the one who looks after us is the LORD.

Verses 2-3 describe the shepherd’s gentle care: green pastures, still waters, a restored soul. These are images of rest, a theme that fits the week well. The shepherd leads. The sheep follow. Note that the paths are “paths of righteousness for his name’s sake.” The shepherd guides his flock in the right way, and his reputation is tied to it. He will not lose those he has promised to keep.

Then comes the valley. David does not claim that the good shepherd leads only through pleasant places. There is a valley of deep darkness, and it is on the path. But look at what changes there. The language shifts in the middle of verse 4 from “he” to “you.” In the dark, David stops talking about God and starts talking to him. “You are with me.” That is the heart of the psalm. The comfort is not an absence of danger but the presence of the shepherd. His rod defends against predators, and his staff guides and rescues. The same tools that protect also comfort.

Verse 5 changes the metaphor from a shepherd to a host. The table is set “in the presence of my enemies.” God’s hospitality is not hidden from those who oppose us. He anoints and fills. The cup overflows. This is the language of extravagant welcome.

The last verse promises that goodness and mercy will pursue David, not just follow. The Hebrew verb is “chase.” All his days, God’s kindness is on his heels. And the final destination is the house of the LORD forever.

For Christians, the shepherd has a name. Jesus said, “I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep” (John 10:11). The psalm takes on its fullest meaning in him. He walked through the valley of death himself, so that when we pass through it, we find him already there.

STEP 5

Connection

The shepherd image is used of God in Genesis 48:15 and 49:24, and of Israel's leaders in Ezekiel 34, where God promises to shepherd his people himself. Jesus claims the title in John 10:1-18, and Hebrews 13:20 calls him "the great shepherd of the sheep." The table before enemies recalls the covenant meals of Exodus 24 and anticipates the Lord's Supper. Revelation 7:17 says the Lamb "will be their shepherd."

STEP 6

Application

Read this psalm aloud once today, slowly. Then tell the Lord one area of your life where you have been behaving like a sheep who thinks it must provide for itself. Hand it over.

If you are in a valley right now, notice the pronoun change. Try praying the second half of verse 4 in your own words: "You are with me." Say it out loud.

If you are in a season of green pastures, receive them with thanks. Don't rush past rest. Ask the Lord what he might be restoring in you.

Finally, ask who you could shepherd this week. A friend, a child, or a younger believer may need your presence. We carry the shepherd's care to others.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell the Lord what you lack, and what you need him to shepherd.
- Ask him to restore your soul, and to remind you he is with you in the dark valley.
- Thank Jesus, the good shepherd.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 31

"Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass."

JOSHUA 21:45

DAY 212 · WEEK 31

Joshua 18:1-19:51

The remaining tribal allotments, every tribe has a place

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 18:1-19:51. These chapters finish the distribution of the land. They begin with a gentle rebuke from Joshua, then describe how the remaining seven tribes receive their portions. Read for the shape of the story: the tabernacle is set up at Shiloh, and every tribe gets a place. Notice the last allotment, Joshua's own.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has taken much of the land, but seven tribes have not yet received their inheritance. The tabernacle has been set up at Shiloh, and the people seem to have settled into a comfortable pause. Joshua asks a sharp question: "How long will you put off going in to take possession of the land?" The solution is a survey. Three men from each tribe are sent out to write a description of the land in seven parts, and Joshua casts lots before the LORD at Shiloh to divide it. The chapter is, in a way, about the danger of delay. God has given the land. The question is whether the people will go and take it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The whole congregation assembles at Shiloh and sets up the tent of meeting there (18:1).
2. "There remained among the people of Israel seven tribes whose inheritance had not yet been apportioned" (18:2).
3. Joshua asks, "How long will you put off going in to take possession of the land, which the LORD, the God of your fathers, has given you?" (18:3).
4. Men are sent to survey the land and write a description in a book (18:4-9).
5. Joshua casts lots for them "before the LORD" (18:10).

6. Benjamin's territory lies between Judah and Joseph and includes Jerusalem (called Jebus) and Gibeon (18:11-28).

7. Simeon's inheritance is taken from within Judah's allotment, "for the portion of the tribe of Judah was too large for them" (19:9).

8. Last of all, Joshua is given the city he asked for, Timnath-serah, "and he rebuilt the city and settled in it" (19:49-50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The tone of chapter 18 is surprising. After the dramatic scenes of Jericho and Ai, the narrator pauses to describe a sluggishness. Seven tribes have not claimed their land, and Joshua asks them why. The question "How long will you put off?" hints at laziness and fear. Some of the territory remained uncleared, and it may have seemed easier to stay at Shiloh near the tabernacle than to go out and face the Canaanites.

This is a familiar spiritual pattern. After a high season of obedience, we can drift into passivity. We feel that God has done enough, and we hesitate to claim what he has given. The promise has been made, but possessing the promise requires effort. Joshua's answer is not a rousing speech. It is a practical plan. He asks the tribes to choose surveyors, write down what they see, and bring it back. The act of describing the land makes the abstract concrete. Sometimes the first step to obedience is simply to look clearly at what God has set before us and write it down.

Then lots are cast "before the LORD" at Shiloh. The use of lots in the Old Testament expressed trust that God, not human cleverness or favoritism, determined the outcome (Proverbs 16:33). The allotments fit each tribe's size and were set by the sovereign God. No tribe was forgotten, and none was able to claim a better deal by pulling strings. Each could say, "This is what the LORD gave me."

The details of Benjamin's land hold a hint of the future. It includes Jerusalem, which will be the city of David and the temple, and Gibeon, where the tabernacle will later rest. Simeon receives land inside Judah, which is a gentle fulfillment of Jacob's prophecy in Genesis 49:7, that Simeon would be scattered in Israel.

The chapter ends with Joshua. The leader of Israel is the last to receive his portion, and he asks for a modest town in the hill country of Ephraim. He has served everyone else first. It is a quiet picture of humble leadership, and it echoes the pattern of the one who came "not to be served but to serve." Joshua's rebuilt city is a small sign that, in Christ, the servant is rewarded with rest.

STEP 5

Connection

Shiloh becomes the center of Israel's worship in Judges and 1 Samuel. The use of lots recalls Numbers 26:55 and Proverbs 16:33. Jacob's words on Simeon are in Genesis 49:5-7. The delay in possessing the promise parallels the call in Hebrews 4:11 to "strive to enter that rest" and anticipates 2 Peter 1:5-10. Joshua's service as the last to receive anticipates Mark 10:45.

STEP 6

Application

Is there an area where God has already given you something and you are still waiting at "Shiloh"? It might be a calling, a gift, a relationship, or a spiritual discipline. Ask yourself, "How long will I put off taking it?" Choose one small first step this week.

Try Joshua's method: look at it clearly, write it down, and make a plan. If you feel a sense of calling but no action, write a one-page description of what it would look like to pursue it.

Remember also that you have been given a portion. You do not need to compare it with anyone else's. Thank God for the specific place and work he has given you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have delayed or been passive in taking what God has given.
- Ask him to show you what he has already given you.
- Ask him for the courage to take hold of it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 31

"Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass."

JOSHUA 21:45

DAY 213 · WEEK 31

Joshua 20:1-22:34

Cities of refuge; Levitical cities; the eastern tribes' altar

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 20:1-22:34. Three episodes fill these chapters: the cities of refuge, the cities given to the Levites, and the near-disaster of the altar built by the eastern tribes. Read the cities of refuge with Hebrews 6:18 in mind, and read the altar story as a lesson in how God's people handle misunderstanding.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The land has been divided, and there are some important administrative matters left. God had commanded Moses to set up cities of refuge, places where someone who had killed another person accidentally could flee for protection from the avenger of blood. The Levites, who received no tribal territory, are given towns and pasturelands. And then the eastern tribes, Reuben, Gad, and half of Manasseh, who had helped the others conquer the land, are sent home. On the way, they build a large altar by the Jordan, and the rest of Israel prepares for civil war. The chapters show a nation learning to live in the land under God's law, and the dangers of misunderstanding within the covenant family.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God tells Joshua to "appoint the cities of refuge, of which I spoke to you through Moses" (20:2).
2. A person who killed "without intent" could flee to a city of refuge and stand before the elders at the gate (20:3-6).
3. The six cities are spread across the land, three on each side of the Jordan (20:7-9).
4. The man could stay there until the death of the high priest who was in office at the time (20:6).

5. Forty-eight cities with pasturelands are given to the Levites (21:1-42).
6. "Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass" (21:45).
7. The eastern tribes build "an altar of imposing size" by the Jordan, and the western tribes gather at Shiloh "to go up against them in war" (22:10-12).
8. Phinehas leads a delegation, and the eastern tribes explain that the altar is a witness, not a place for sacrifice (22:21-29, 34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The cities of refuge are an expression of both justice and mercy. The law required that a murderer be put to death, but it also recognized that not every killing is murder. If someone killed another by accident, the avenger of blood could still pursue him, and the refuge was there to protect him. The elders of the city would hear his case, and he would be shielded until a proper trial. And the release came with the death of the high priest. This is one of the most interesting details in the whole system. The high priest's death brings freedom for those who are confined. The author of Hebrews uses this kind of reasoning, because the death of our great high priest gives freedom to all who have fled to him for refuge. The six cities were also placed so that no one was too far from one. In Christ, the refuge is always near.

The Levite cities show God's care for those who serve him. They do not hold a block of land, but they live among every tribe, as teachers and priests, so that the whole nation would be reached. The summary in 21:43-45 is among the most important statements in the book. "Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass." The narrator pauses to record God's faithfulness. It is a statement that is both historic and prophetic, since the story of Judges will immediately show the tragic ways Israel fails. But God does not fail.

Chapter 22 is a drama of near catastrophe. The eastern tribes erect an altar, and the western tribes assume it is rebellion. They are ready to go to war, and they cite Peor and Achan as precedents. But first they send a delegation, led by Phinehas, who is a priest and the zealous son of Eleazar. The meeting is a model of conflict resolution. The delegates come with questions and with a genuine concern for the covenant. The eastern tribes reply by explaining their motive. They had feared that future generations of western Israel would say, "You have no portion in the LORD." The altar was built as a witness that they too belong to Israel. Phinehas and the leaders are satisfied, and the potential war is replaced by a blessing. The altar is named "Witness."

The lesson is twofold. Zeal for God must be married to listening. And the unity of God's people depends on honest communication. Division is often the result of assumptions. Many church conflicts could be avoided if believers followed the pattern of Phinehas, who went and asked before acting.

STEP 5

Connection

The law of refuge appears in Numbers 35 and Deuteronomy 19. Hebrews 6:18 speaks of those who "have fled for refuge" to lay hold of the hope in Christ. The Levite cities fulfill Numbers 35:1-8. Joshua 21:45 is echoed in 23:14 and 1 Kings 8:56. The earlier eastern tribes' agreement is in Numbers 32. The reference to Peor and Achan recalls Numbers 25 and Joshua 7. Matthew 18:15-20 gives a New Testament pattern for dealing with conflict.

STEP 6

Application

First, take refuge. If you feel guilt or fear, remember that Christ is a city of refuge for those who run to him. Take a specific burden to him today and rest there.

Second, consider whom you might be misjudging. Is there a person or a group you have assumed the worst about? Before acting, follow Phinehas: go and ask. Choose one relationship where a direct and gracious conversation could clear the air.

Third, receive the testimony of verse 45. Write it on a card: "Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made… had failed." Read it when you are tempted to doubt.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Run to Christ with your guilt, and tell him what it is.
- Ask him to make you quick to ask before you accuse.
- Thank him for being your city of refuge.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 31

“Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass.”

JOSHUA 21:45

DAY 214 · WEEK 31

Joshua 23:1-24:33

Joshua's farewell; covenant renewal, choose this day

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joshua 23:1-24:33. The book closes with two farewell speeches and a covenant ceremony. Read chapter 23 as an old man's pastoral warning, and chapter 24 as one of the great covenant renewals in the Bible. Note the question at the center: "Choose this day whom you will serve."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Joshua is old, and he knows he will die soon. Like Moses before him, he gathers Israel to give them final instructions. The first speech, in chapter 23, is to the leaders. It is a mixture of reminder and warning. The second, in chapter 24, takes place at Shechem, the place where God first gave Abraham the promise of the land, and where Israel had pronounced the blessings and curses. Joshua retells the story from Abraham to the present and then calls the people to a decision. This is the book's climax, and it explains what everything has been for. God has kept his promises. Will his people keep faith with him?

STEP 3

Observation

1. Joshua says, "You have seen all that the LORD your God has done… for it is the LORD your God who has fought for you" (23:3).
2. "Be very strong to keep and to do all that is written in the Book of the Law of Moses" (23:6).
3. He warns against intermarrying with the nations and serving their gods, for "they shall be a snare and a trap for you" (23:12-13).
4. At Shechem, Joshua recounts the history from Terah and Abraham, who "served other gods" beyond the River, up to the conquest (24:2-13).

5. “Now therefore fear the LORD and serve him in sincerity and in faithfulness. Put away the gods that your fathers served” (24:14).
6. “Choose this day whom you will serve… But as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD” (24:15).
7. The people say, “Far be it from us that we should forsake the LORD,” and Joshua replies, “You are not able to serve the LORD, for he is a holy God” (24:16-19).
8. Joshua sets up a stone as a witness, and the book ends with the burials of Joshua, Joseph’s bones, and Eleazar (24:26-33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Joshua’s farewell has the weight of a last testament. He reminds the leaders that the victories were God’s: “it is the LORD your God who has fought for you.” Then he issues a conditional warning. If they cling to the LORD, the nations will be driven out. If they turn aside and join the nations, they will be a snare and a trap, and they will perish from the good land. The word “if” is a reminder that enjoying the inheritance requires faithfulness. The relationship is a covenant, and covenants have promises and responsibilities.

The scene at Shechem is the great moment. Joshua recites the history of salvation: God took Abraham from idolatrous Mesopotamia, gave him a family, delivered them from Egypt, defeated the Amorites, and gave them a land they did not labor for and cities they did not build. It is a summary of grace. Everything the people have is a gift. Then the “therefore” comes. Because God has done all this, fear him and serve him. Obedience in the Bible is always a response to grace.

Then the famous verse. “Choose this day whom you will serve.” It is not a neutral invitation. Joshua presents the options bluntly: the gods beyond the river, the gods of the Amorites, or the LORD. There is no fourth option of serving no one. Everyone worships something. Then he gives his own testimony: “But as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD.” The decision is personal and also household-wide. A leader’s faith carries weight in his family.

The people respond confidently, but Joshua’s next statement is startling: “You are not able to serve the LORD, for he is a holy God.” This is not discouragement but realism. The people are overconfident. They think they can serve God by their own resolution. Joshua knows that a holy God demands more than good intentions. The law cannot make anyone holy. This is the very question the New Testament will answer. God provides in Christ what the law demanded, and by his Spirit he writes the law on our hearts. We are not able. He is.

The covenant is renewed with a stone as witness. The book ends with burials, a note of closure. Joseph's bones, carried from Egypt for four hundred years, are finally laid to rest at Shechem. The promise made to him in Genesis 50:25 has been kept. And Joshua dies, called "the servant of the LORD," a title previously given only to Moses. The next book will show what happens when the leader is gone.

STEP 5

Connection

Joshua 24 echoes the covenant formats of Deuteronomy and the ancient suzerainty treaties. The history from Abraham to the conquest summarizes Genesis through Joshua. The burial of Joseph's bones fulfills Genesis 50:24-25 and Exodus 13:19. The warning about intermarriage recalls Deuteronomy 7:1-4. The inability to serve a holy God anticipates Romans 8:3, Hebrews 10, and Jeremiah 31. Jesus quotes the spirit of this choice in Matthew 6:24, "You cannot serve God and money."

STEP 6

Application

Take Joshua's question seriously: whom are you serving? Not in theory, but in practice. Look at where your time, money, and attention flow. Is there a "god" that has quietly taken a throne in your heart? Name it, and renounce it.

Make the household decision. If you have a spouse, children, or roommates, ask what "as for me and my house" might look like in practice: a shared meal and a prayer, a habit of reading Scripture together, a commitment to a church.

Finally, receive the sober words of verse 19. You are not able to serve God in your own strength. Say that honestly to him, and then rely on the Spirit and on Christ's righteousness to be what you cannot be on your own.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you choose today, and who you want to serve with.
- Ask him to show you any idols you still keep and to give strength to put them away.
- Pray for your household or those closest to you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 31

“Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass.”

JOSHUA 21:45

DAY 215 · WEEK 31

Judges 1:1-3:31

Incomplete conquest; the cycle begins; the first judges

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 1:1-3:31. This is the longest reading of the week, and it introduces a new era. Notice how the book begins by mirroring Joshua, then slowly shows decline. Pay special attention to 2:6-3:6, which gives the key to the whole book, and to the stories of Othniel, Ehud, and Shamgar.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Joshua is dead, and a whole generation passes. The book of Judges tells what happens next. It covers roughly three hundred years, from the death of Joshua to just before the monarchy, and it is a dark and honest account. Israel has the land but not the faithfulness to keep it. The opening chapter reports tribe-by-tribe incomplete conquest. The next chapters explain why: Israel's failure to drive out the nations and its habit of worshiping their gods. The book then introduces a repeating pattern that will shape every story to come. This is the most important thing to grasp as you start Judges. The stories are not about heroes. They are about a people who keep forgetting, and a God who keeps saving.

STEP 3

Observation

1. After Joshua's death, Israel asks the LORD, "Who shall go up first for us against the Canaanites?" and the LORD says Judah (1:1-2).
2. The first chapter lists repeated failures: "did not drive out" appears again and again (1:19, 21, 27-33).
3. The angel of the LORD at Bochim rebukes Israel for making covenants with the inhabitants and not breaking down their altars (2:1-5).

4. “There arose another generation after them who did not know the LORD or the work that he had done for Israel” (2:10).
5. Israel “did what was evil in the sight of the LORD and served the Baals” (2:11).
6. The pattern: sin, oppression, cry for help, deliverance by a judge, rest, then relapse (2:11-19).
7. Othniel, Caleb’s nephew, delivers Israel and the land has rest forty years (3:7-11).
8. Ehud, a left-handed Benjaminite, kills the fat king Eglon (3:12-30). Shamgar strikes down six hundred Philistines with an oxgoad (3:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book of Judges opens with an echo and a shadow. The question, “Who shall go up first for us?” mirrors the opening of Joshua, and God’s answer is Judah, just as Genesis 49 would suggest. For a few verses, it seems the conquest will continue. But the language quickly changes. “Did not drive out.” This phrase becomes the drumbeat of the chapter, a quiet record of compromise. The tribes of Benjamin, Manasseh, Ephraim, Zebulun, Asher, Naphtali, and Dan each fail to dislodge the Canaanites. The theme is partial obedience. Israel is not rebelling openly, but it is settling for less than God had commanded.

The angel of the LORD arrives at Bochim, “the weepers,” and gives the reason. Israel had made treaties with the people of the land and left their altars standing. They were warned. The consequences are described: the nations will become thorns and their gods a snare. The people weep, and offer a sacrifice, but there is no real repentance. This will be a pattern.

The center of the section is 2:6-3:6, which is the theological preface to the whole book. The generation of Joshua dies, and another arises that “did not know the LORD or the work that he had done.” This is one of the saddest sentences in the Bible. The faith was not handed down. Joshua had built the memorial stones, but the story was not told. Then the cycle begins. Israel does evil, God gives them into the hands of oppressors, they cry out, and God raises up a judge to save them. But when the judge dies, the people go back, and they do so even worse than their fathers. The pattern is a spiral downward.

It is important to see that the judges are not moral exemplars. They are “saviors” whom God raises up, flawed and often surprising. Othniel is the one clean example, a faithful man from Caleb’s family. Ehud is a trickster who uses his left hand and a hidden blade. Shamgar is a rough farmer with an oxgoad. The point is not their virtue but God’s compassion. Judges 2:18 says, “the LORD was moved to pity by their groaning.” God saves not because Israel deserves it but because he is merciful.

Why does God leave some nations in the land? Judges 2:22 and 3:1-4 say it was to test Israel, to see whether they would keep the way of the LORD, and to teach war to the generations who had not known it. The testing exposes the heart. And it creates a longing. If these saviors are so flawed and the people so fickle, we begin to ask for a better savior and a king who will truly lead. Judges is the book that makes the reader long for Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

The failure to drive out the nations contradicts Deuteronomy 7:1-6 and Joshua 23:12-13. The loss of memory in 2:10 contrasts with Deuteronomy 6:4-9, 20-25. The cycle pattern echoes Leviticus 26 and Deuteronomy 28. Othniel's story ties back to Joshua 15:16-19. The repeated "cry out" and God's pity recall Exodus 2:23-25. The judges anticipate the greater Savior of Luke 1:68-75.

STEP 6

Application

First, consider the failure to pass on the faith. If you have children, grandchildren, or others you are discipling, ask what you are doing to tell them what God has done. Plan one concrete step this week, such as sharing a testimony or reading a psalm together.

Second, examine your own cycle. We all have patterns: sin, consequences, a cry for help, forgiveness, and, too often, a return. Where do you see this? Ask the Lord to help you move from regret to repentance and from repentance to a changed life.

Third, take comfort in God's pity. He was "moved to pity by their groaning." He still is. Bring your groaning to him without hiding it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess partial obedience and a short memory, as you see them in your own heart.

Ask him to teach you to tell the next generation what he has done.

Thank him that he is moved to pity by his people's groaning.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 31

“Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass.”

JOSHUA 21:45

DAY 216 · WEEK 31

Judges 4:1-5:31

Deborah and Barak; the song of Deborah

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 4:1-5:31. The reading includes the story of Deborah and Barak in prose (chapter 4) and a poem of victory (chapter 5). Notice the two women, Deborah and Jael, who play central roles in a book that is otherwise dominated by men. Read the Song of Deborah aloud, if you can.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The cycle of Judges continues. After Ehud's rest, Israel again does evil, and God sells them into the hand of Jabin, a king of Canaan who reigns in Hazor, with a commander named Sisera and nine hundred iron chariots. For twenty years he oppresses Israel. Then comes a remarkable judge, Deborah, a prophetess who sits under a palm tree and settles disputes. She summons Barak, and the story that follows is about courage, hesitation, and the surprising ways God works. The poem in chapter 5 is one of the oldest in the Bible. It celebrates the victory and also names who joined the battle and who stayed home.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Deborah is a prophetess and judge who holds court "under the palm of Deborah" in the hill country of Ephraim (4:4-5).
2. She tells Barak that the LORD commands him to gather ten thousand men to Mount Tabor, and promises to give Sisera into his hand (4:6-7).
3. Barak says, "If you will go with me, I will go, but if you will not go with me, I will not go" (4:8).
4. Deborah replies that the honor will go to a woman, and the LORD will sell Sisera into the hand of a woman (4:9).

5. “The LORD routed Sisera and all his chariots and all his army” (4:15).
6. Sisera flees on foot to the tent of Jael, wife of Heber the Kenite, who gives him milk, covers him, and drives a tent peg through his temple (4:17-21).
7. The Song of Deborah praises the LORD who “marched from Seir,” and notes that the stars fought from heaven and the river Kishon swept the enemy away (5:4-5, 20-21).
8. The song blesses Jael above women and curses Meroz for not coming to the help of the LORD (5:23-24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Deborah is one of the most striking figures in the book. In a world dominated by male warriors, God raises up a woman as a prophet and judge. She does not lead the army herself, but she delivers the word of the LORD, and her authority is recognized by Barak and the tribes. Her role should remind us that God is not bound by cultural expectations about whom he will use, and that the gifts of prophecy and wisdom come from him.

Barak’s hesitation is also instructive. God has already spoken, and the promise is clear. Yet Barak says he will not go without Deborah. His reluctance is not necessarily cowardice. It may show how much he depends on God’s presence through the prophet. But it costs him. The honor of the final blow will go to a woman. The story then contains a reversal: the conquering general of the iron chariots is brought down by a Kenite woman in a tent.

The battle itself is told briefly. God routs Sisera and his army, and the poem fills in the detail: the stars fought, and the river Kishon swept them away. The text gives the glory to God. The mighty chariots, the Canaanites’ most powerful weapon, are neutralized by a flood. Yet again, God shows that victory does not depend on military strength.

Jael’s act is both shocking and ambiguous. She welcomes a fleeing enemy with hospitality and then kills him in his sleep. The narrator does not condemn or praise her explicitly in chapter 4, but the song in chapter 5 blesses her. She has chosen sides, as an outsider who aligned herself with the people of God. Like Rahab, she is a non-Israelite who joins God’s side. We need not imitate her method. The point is that God uses unexpected people.

The Song of Deborah is a masterwork of praise. It begins with the LORD marching from Seir, a reminder of Sinai, and credits God with the whole victory. It lists the tribes who volunteered and those who stayed behind. Reuben “had great searchings of heart” but remained among the sheepfolds. Meroz is cursed for not coming “to the help of the LORD.” The song shows that the people of God are summoned to take part in his work, and neutrality is not an option.

The final line of the song is a prayer: “So may all your enemies perish, O LORD! But your friends be like the sun as he rises in his might.” The victory of God’s people is a picture of the final victory of Christ, the true seed of the woman who crushes the head of the serpent (Genesis 3:15). Sisera’s death by a woman’s hand is a small echo of that promise.

STEP 5

Connection

The defeat of Jabin and Hazor recalls Joshua 11. The Song of Deborah parallels the Song of Moses (Exodus 15) and Hannah’s song (1 Samuel 2). The imagery of the LORD marching from Seir is also in Deuteronomy 33:2 and Habakkuk 3:3-6. The crushing of the head echoes Genesis 3:15, and Mary’s Magnificat in Luke 1:46-55 follows the same pattern of reversal. Jael is mentioned in Judges 5 as “most blessed of women,” a phrase later applied to Mary in Luke 1:42.

STEP 6

Application

First, think about the ways you hesitate to obey. Like Barak, we may say yes to God, but only if some condition is met. Ask yourself whether you are waiting for something God has not promised before you obey.

Second, be willing to take part. The song blesses those who came and warns those who stayed behind. Is there a need in your church that you have been standing back from? Offer your time or talent in one specific way.

Third, learn from Deborah. She exercised her gift without apology and gave God the glory. Whatever your gifting, use it in service.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he uses unexpected people.
- Confess where you have hesitated to obey him.
- Ask him to help you join his work today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 31

“Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass.”

JOSHUA 21:45

DAY 217 · WEEK 31

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you finished the book of Joshua and began Judges. You read about the land being divided, the cities of refuge, and Joshua's farewell, and then you watched the nation begin to unravel. Take a moment today to hold both together: a God who never fails, and a people who often do.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass."

JOSHUA 21:45

REST

Meditation

Joshua 21:45 is the hinge between two books. It closes the story of Joshua with a statement of God's perfect faithfulness, and it throws a bright light on the sadness of Judges that follows.

"Not one word." Not most, not nearly all. The promises made to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, and renewed to Moses and Joshua, had been kept in full. After centuries of slavery, wandering, and war, the record says nothing has failed.

"Of all the good promises." The word "good" reminds us that God's promises are not threats. They are gifts. He promised a land, rest, victory, and presence, and he gave them.

"That the LORD had made to the house of Israel." The promises were made to a people, and they were kept for a people. They were also kept for the world, because through this people came the Messiah.

“All came to pass.” The statement is complete. Whatever Israel did or did not do, the LORD was faithful.

This verse will be tested immediately by Judges, where Israel is unfaithful and suffers for it. But God does not fail even then. Paul’s words in 2 Corinthians 1:20 make the point: “All the promises of God find their Yes in him.” Every promise God has made is secured in Christ. Carry this verse into the week. When you wonder whether God will keep his word to you, remember that he has never failed.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you walked through a long arc. You sang Psalm 23 and rested in the shepherd. You read the remaining tribal allotments and Joshua’s rebuke to those who delayed possessing the land. You studied the cities of refuge, the cities of the Levites, and the near-war over the altar by the Jordan, and you saw how Phinehas resolved it by asking first. You read Joshua’s farewell at Shechem, with its great challenge, “Choose this day whom you will serve,” and the sober reminder that no one is able to serve a holy God in his own strength. Then you opened Judges. You saw the incomplete conquest, the generation that did not know the LORD, and the repeating cycle of sin and rescue. You met Othniel, Ehud, Shamgar, and then Deborah, Barak, and Jael, and heard the song of victory.

The week held a sharp contrast: God’s faithfulness is complete, and his people’s faithfulness is not.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

What is your “Shiloh”? Joshua asked the tribes how long they would put off taking what God had given. Is there something you have been waiting on, such as a step of obedience, a conversation, a calling, or a discipline? What is the first small step, and when will you take it?

How does Joshua’s statement, “You are not able to serve the LORD, for he is a holy God,” point you to Jesus? The people were confident they could keep the covenant, and they could not. Christ kept it perfectly on our behalf, and he gives his Spirit to write the law on our hearts. What changes for you when you stop trying to serve God in your own strength and start from what Christ has done?

Whom are you passing the faith on to? Judges 2:10 describes a generation that "did not know the LORD or the work that he had done." Think of one younger person in your life, such as a child, a niece, a friend, or a fellow church member. What is one story of God's faithfulness you could tell them this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that not one of his promises has failed.

Thank Christ in whom every promise is yes.

Confess any distrust, and rest in his faithfulness.

DAY 218 · WEEK 32

Psalm 46

God is our refuge and strength

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 46 aloud. It is a psalm of the Sons of Korah, and it was the inspiration for Luther's hymn "A Mighty Fortress." Read it three times: first for the images of chaos, second for the images of the city of God, and third for the repeated refrain, "The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the sobering opening of Judges, with its picture of a nation in decline, this psalm opens the week with a different note. It is about security in the middle of chaos. The psalm sets the shaking of the earth, the roaring of the seas, and the raging of nations against one unshakable fact: God is with his people. It was likely sung in Jerusalem, perhaps after a deliverance such as Sennacherib's defeat. Whatever its original setting, it makes a powerful companion to the book of Judges, where God's people were constantly in crisis and God was constantly their refuge.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble" (v. 1).
2. "Therefore we will not fear though the earth gives way, though the mountains be moved into the heart of the sea" (v. 2).
3. The waters "roar and foam" and the mountains "tremble at its swelling" (v. 3).
4. "There is a river whose streams make glad the city of God, the holy habitation of the Most High" (v. 4).
5. "God is in the midst of her; she shall not be moved; God will help her when morning dawns" (v. 5).

6. “The nations rage, the kingdoms totter; he utters his voice, the earth melts” (v. 6).
7. The refrain: “The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress” (vv. 7, 11).
8. “Be still, and know that I am God. I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted in the earth” (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a bold claim: God is not just a refuge from trouble but a “very present help in trouble.” The Hebrew phrase suggests that he is readily found. You do not have to search for him. In the moment of crisis, he is there. The consequence follows at once: “Therefore we will not fear.” Fear is not removed by changing circumstances but by a deeper fact.

The first stanza uses the language of cosmic catastrophe. Mountains fall into the sea, and waters roar. In the ancient world, the sea was the symbol of chaos, and the mountains were the symbol of stability. The psalm imagines both of these being undone. If anything could shake a believer, it would be this. Yet the declaration is, “we will not fear.” The point is not that disasters never come, but that they cannot unseat the God who is present with us.

The second stanza turns to the city of God. There is a river whose streams make it glad. This is striking, because Jerusalem had no river. The psalm is describing something spiritual: the presence of God is the river that nourishes his people. It echoes Eden’s river in Genesis 2 and anticipates the river of the water of life in Revelation 22. In the midst of this city, God dwells. “She shall not be moved.” While the mountains shake, the city stays secure, because God is in her.

The third stanza shifts to the nations and the end of war. The LORD speaks, and the earth melts. He breaks the bow and burns the chariots. The psalm ends with a call: “Be still, and know that I am God.” This is not a gentle invitation to quiet meditation, though it can include that. In context, it is a command to the raging nations to cease their fighting. “Be still” means “stop” or “let go.” But it is also a word to God’s people. When we are anxious, we are told to cease striving and acknowledge God’s rule. The knowledge of God’s sovereignty is the antidote to panic.

The refrain, “The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress,” ties together the great and the small. He is the commander of heaven’s armies, and he is the God of Jacob, the God who chose a flawed man and bound himself to him. This is the God who stands with Israel in the book of Judges, and with the church today. His name for us in the New Testament is Immanuel, “God with us.”

STEP 5

Connection

The river echoes Genesis 2:10, Ezekiel 47, and Revelation 22:1-2. The deliverance of Jerusalem recalls Isaiah 36-37. The breaking of the bow is also promised in Hosea 2:18 and Zechariah 9:10. “The LORD of hosts is with us” prepares for Isaiah 7:14 and Matthew 1:23, “Immanuel.” Jesus stills the storm in Mark 4:35-41, which shows that he is the God of this psalm.

STEP 6

Application

Identify one area where fear has taken hold. Perhaps it is health, work, a family concern, or the news. Read verses 1-3 and say, “Therefore I will not fear.” Then speak the refrain aloud.

Practice stillness. Set a timer for five minutes today, and in silence, simply repeat “Be still, and know that I am God.” Notice what you are tempted to do instead.

Finally, praise God for his presence in the church. The city of God is not shaken, even when its members are. Thank him for the community he has given you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you are afraid of, and speak Psalm 46:1 over it.
- Ask him to quiet your striving and teach you to be still.
- Thank him that in Christ he is with you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 32

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 219 · WEEK 32

Psalm 76

In Judah God is known, the God who breaks bows

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 76. It is a short song of victory that celebrates God's defeat of his enemies in Jerusalem. It is thought to be connected to the deliverance of the city from Sennacherib, and it ties naturally with Psalm 46. Notice the movement from God's dwelling place to his judgment of the earth.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

A psalm of Asaph, Psalm 76 sits alongside Psalm 46 as a song of Zion. Both celebrate God's protection of his city and his power over the nations. This psalm is slightly different, though. It concentrates on the character of God as a warrior and a judge. "In Judah God is known; his name is great in Israel." It is a reminder that the God of Israel is not just a tribal deity but the one who breaks weapons and brings kings low. For a church reading Judges, it is a statement that no oppressor, no matter how strong, can ultimately withstand him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In Judah God is known; his name is great in Israel" (v. 1).
2. "His abode has been established in Salem, his dwelling place in Zion" (v. 2).
3. "There he broke the flashing arrows, the shield, the sword, and the weapons of war" (v. 3).
4. God is "more majestic than the mountains full of prey" (v. 4).
5. "The stouthearted were stripped of their spoil; they sank into sleep; all the men of war were unable to use their hands" (v. 5).
6. "At your rebuke, O God of Jacob, both rider and horse lay stunned" (v. 6).

7. “You, you are to be feared! Who can stand before you when once your anger is roused?” (v. 7).

8. “You make the earth afraid and still, when God arose to establish judgment, to save all the humble of the earth” (vv. 8-9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 76 sings of a victory that no one on Israel’s side won. The weapons were broken. The warriors slept. The horse and rider lay stunned. There is little mention of Israel’s army, because the victory was God’s. The theme of divine warfare, which you saw throughout Joshua and Judges, is here turned into worship.

Notice the first verse. “In Judah God is known.” This is not just a statement of geography but a statement of revelation. God has made himself known in a particular people and a particular place. His dwelling in Salem, which is Jerusalem, was the center of Israel’s worship. It recalls Melchizedek, the priest-king of Salem in Genesis 14, whom you read about earlier. The city that would hold the temple was already associated with that mysterious priest.

The psalm’s depiction of God is both terrifying and comforting. He is “more majestic than the mountains full of prey.” This image suggests that all earthly powers, the predators of the world, are small compared to him. He is to be feared. “Who can stand before you when once your anger is roused?” The answer is no one. But the psalm’s purpose in saying this is salvation. Verse 9 says God arose to establish judgment “to save all the humble of the earth.” The anger that terrifies the proud is the same power that rescues the humble. For those who trust him, his might is a shelter.

The final stanza makes a surprising turn. Even the wrath of man shall praise him. God uses the rage of his enemies to display his glory, and what is left over he restrains. This is a sweeping statement of divine sovereignty. Even the wickedness of the wicked ends up serving the purposes of God. The cross is the ultimate example: the wrath of men against Christ was the means of salvation.

The psalm ends with a call to action. “Make your vows to the LORD your God and perform them.” Because God is the victorious judge, his people are to respond with worship and fidelity. And all around him are to bring gifts to “him who is to be feared.” The psalm has moved from the mountains to the nations to the lives of individual worshipers.

STEP 5

Connection

Salem links to Genesis 14:18 and Hebrews 7:1-2. Both Psalm 46 and Psalm 76 reflect the deliverance in Isaiah 37. The idea that God uses human wrath for his glory is seen in Genesis 50:20, Exodus 9:16, and Acts 4:27-28. The promise to save “the humble of the earth” echoes Psalm 37:11 and Matthew 5:5. Revelation 19 shows the final victory of the Lord over the nations.

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on whom you fear. If you are anxious about powerful people, institutions, or circumstances, read verse 7 aloud. The one who can stand before God is no one. And the one who trusts him need not fear anyone else.

Make a vow and keep it. The psalm ends with a call to fulfill vows to God. Think of a commitment you have made to him or to others, such as a promise to pray, to serve, or to give. Renew it and take one practical step.

Finally, trust that God can use even hostility for good. If you are facing opposition, ask him to bring praise from it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Stand in awe of God’s majesty, in your own words.
- Ask him to keep you from fearing anyone but him.
- Thank him that he saves the humble.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 32

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 220 · WEEK 32

Judges 6:1-8:35

Gideon called; the fleece; the 300; victory and aftermath

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 98 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 6:1-8:35. This is a long reading, so read it in three movements: Gideon's call and the fleece (chapter 6), the victory with three hundred men (chapter 7), and the aftermath (chapter 8). Keep in mind the verse that stands behind the story: "Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has again done evil, and this time the Midianites oppress them so severely that the people hide in caves and mountain strongholds. Every harvest is stripped by swarms of raiders "like locusts." Into this misery God sends a prophet to remind Israel why they are suffering, and then he sends an angel to a farmer named Gideon, who is threshing wheat in a winepress to hide it from the Midianites. Gideon is not the obvious choice for a hero. The stories that follow show a man who is hesitant, who tests God, and who triumphs only because God shrinks his army to nothing. But they also show how quickly a victory can become a snare.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The angel of the LORD greets Gideon, "The LORD is with you, O mighty man of valor" (6:12), while Gideon is hiding.
2. Gideon objects, "My clan is the weakest in Manasseh, and I am the least in my father's house" (6:15).
3. He tears down his father's altar of Baal and Asherah by night, and is nicknamed Jerubbaal (6:25-32).

4. Gideon asks for a sign with the fleece, first wet with dew while the ground is dry, then the reverse (6:36-40).
5. God reduces the army from 32,000 to 10,000 to 300, “lest Israel boast over me” (7:2-8).
6. The 300 carry trumpets, empty jars, and torches, and shout, “For the LORD and for Gideon!” (7:16-20).
7. The Ephraimites complain that they were not called sooner, and Gideon soothes them with a gentle answer (8:1-3).
8. Gideon refuses the kingship but makes an ephod from the gold, which “became a snare to Gideon and to his house” (8:22-27).
9. After the victory, the land has rest for forty years, but when Gideon dies Israel again goes after the Baals (8:28-35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The angel’s greeting is deliberately ironic. “The LORD is with you, O mighty man of valor.” Gideon is at the winepress, hiding. God speaks to who he will make him, not who he is now. This is a pattern in the Bible: God sees what he will do through the person, not just their present weakness. Gideon’s response is one of honest objection. “If the LORD is with us, why then has all this happened to us?” It is a real question, and God does not scold him for it. Instead, God answers with a promise: “I will be with you.”

Before Gideon can defeat the Midianites, he must deal with idolatry at home. God tells him to tear down his father’s altar to Baal, and Gideon does it at night, afraid of the people. It is a small act of faith with big consequences. The first battle is always internal. We cannot expect God to defeat our enemies while we shelter our idols.

The fleece story is often misread as a model for guidance. In fact, Gideon had already received a clear word from God, and the fleece shows his unbelief. Still, God graciously answers. The lesson is not that we should seek signs, but that God is patient with weak faith. The better way is to trust his word without needing proof.

The reduction of the army is the center of the story. God says that 32,000 is too many “lest Israel boast over me, saying, ‘My own hand has saved me.’” Twenty-two thousand leave out of fear, and the remaining 10,000 are reduced to 300 by their way of drinking water. The strategy makes the victory unmistakable. Three hundred men with trumpets, jars, and torches defeat a host “like locusts in abundance.” The point is not the cleverness of the plan but its absurdity. God’s power is made perfect in weakness, as Paul will say in 2 Corinthians 12:9.

But the story does not end in triumph. In chapter 8, Gideon deals with Ephraim wisely, but takes brutal revenge on the towns that refused him supplies. He refuses the crown with the right words, "The LORD will rule over you," but then asks for gold and makes an ephod. The ephod becomes an idol, and "all Israel whored after it there." The man who tore down Baal's altar ends by building a rival object of worship. Even the best of the judges fail. The people forget God as soon as Gideon dies. The tragedy shows that Israel's problem is not just a lack of leaders but a hardness of heart. It is a heart problem that no judge can fix.

STEP 5

Connection

The call of Gideon echoes Moses at the burning bush (Exodus 3-4). The shrinking army anticipates 1 Samuel 14:6 and 2 Chronicles 20. The smashing of the jars to reveal the light is echoed in 2 Corinthians 4:7, "we have this treasure in jars of clay." The ephod's failure recalls the golden calf of Exodus 32. Gideon appears in Hebrews 11:32 as a man of faith. The principle of strength through weakness is expressed in 1 Corinthians 1:27-29.

STEP 6

Application

Think of how God sees you. Gideon was addressed as a "mighty man of valor" while he was hiding. In Christ, you are called a saint, a child of God, and a new creation. Ask the Lord to help you live into what he says you are.

Examine the "ephod" risk. After a spiritual success, we can be tempted to build a monument to ourselves or to something that distracts from God. What victories in your life might become a snare if you start to trust them?

Finally, embrace your weakness. If you feel inadequate for what God has put before you, hear the point of the 300. He chooses small instruments so that the glory is his.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to tear down the idols in your house.

Thank him that he wins with the weak, and tell him where you feel weak.

Ask him to keep you from boasting in yourself.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 32

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 221 · WEEK 32

Judges 9:1-10:18

Abimelech's treachery; the parable of the trees

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 9:1-10:18. This is one of the darkest stretches of the book. Abimelech, Gideon's son, murders his brothers and makes himself king. Read Jotham's parable of the trees carefully. It is a sharp piece of political satire with a prophetic punch.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Gideon has died, and Israel immediately returns to the Baals. Gideon's son by a concubine, Abimelech, sees an opportunity. He persuades the leaders of Shechem to make him king, and then he murders seventy of his half-brothers on a single stone. One brother, Jotham, escapes, and from the top of Mount Gerizim he tells a parable. This chapter is a warning about what happens when power is seized by a man with no fear of God. It is also a sign that Israel is sliding from a nation of tribes toward a kingdom, but toward the wrong kind of king. The chapter closes with two more brief judges, Tola and Jair, and another round of oppression.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Abimelech persuades his mother's family to say to the leaders of Shechem, "Which is better for you, that all seventy of the sons of Jerubbaal rule over you, or that one rule over you?" (9:2).
2. The leaders give him seventy pieces of silver from the temple of Baal-berith, and he hires worthless and reckless fellows (9:4).
3. He kills his seventy brothers "on one stone," but Jotham, the youngest, hides (9:5).
4. Jotham's parable: the olive tree, the fig tree, and the vine each refuse to rule, but the bramble agrees (9:7-15).

5. Jotham says, “let fire come out from Abimelech and devour the leaders of Shechem” (9:20).
6. “God sent an evil spirit between Abimelech and the leaders of Shechem” (9:23).
7. A woman drops a millstone on Abimelech’s head, and he asks his armor-bearer to kill him so that it will not be said a woman killed him (9:53-54).
8. “Thus God repaid the evil of Abimelech… and the evil of the men of Shechem God also repaid” (9:56-57).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Abimelech is a picture of the corruption of power. His name means “my father is king,” which says everything about his ambitions. He uses his family connections, the money from a pagan temple, and a gang of thugs to take control. The leaders of Shechem, who make him king, are complicit. They are willing to trade their loyalty to Jerubbaal’s family for a more convenient ruler, and they fund him from the treasury of Baal. The corruption is spiritual and political at once.

Jotham’s parable is the intellectual heart of the chapter. The trees go out to anoint a king. The olive tree, the fig tree, and the vine are all fruitful and useful, and each declines the offer, preferring to continue producing good things. Only the bramble, which produces nothing and is only good for burning, accepts. The sharp point is that those worth following have better things to do than seek power, and those who crave it are often the least fit. The bramble’s offer, “take refuge in my shade,” is absurd. A bramble offers no shade, and a fire may come from it.

The prophecy comes true. Within three years, God raises up strife between Abimelech and Shechem. The conspirators turn on each other, and both are destroyed. The narrator says plainly that God was repaying the evil done to the house of Gideon. The chapter is a case study in justice working itself out through the very sins people commit. Those who live by violence die by violence. Abimelech is killed by a millstone dropped from a tower by a woman, and his death is a bitter mockery of his pride.

The meaning is hardly cheerful, but it is clear. Human kingship without God is a bramble. It grasps, it burns, and it destroys. This sets the stage for a longer story. Israel will ask for a king in 1 Samuel, and the first, Saul, will be a disappointment. Only David will be a man after God’s own heart, and even he will fail. The longing for a true king runs through the whole Old Testament. The perfect king is the one who did not grasp at power but took the form of a

servant. Philippians 2:5-8 describes the opposite of Abimelech. Christ, who had every right to rule, humbled himself and died. The true king is the true olive tree, the one who does not seek his own glory but gives himself.

Chapter 10 closes with a short note on two minor judges and then a statement of Israel's apostasy: they serve the Baals, the Ashtaroth, and the gods of seven nations. God finally says, "I will save you no more," but when they put away their foreign gods, "he became impatient over the misery of Israel." His compassion overcomes his anger.

STEP 5

Connection

Abimelech's story echoes Cain's murder of Abel (Genesis 4) and Absalom's rebellion (2 Samuel 15). The parable of the trees is a fable like Nathan's parable in 2 Samuel 12. The woman and the millstone appear again in 2 Samuel 11:21. Shechem was the place of the covenant in Joshua 24, and its fall here shows how far Israel has drifted. The true King contrasts with the bramble in Philippians 2:5-11 and Mark 10:42-45.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself what drives your ambitions. Are there areas where you are grasping for position, recognition, or control? Pray over them, and ask the Lord to give you the humility of Christ.

Consider whom you follow. The leaders of Shechem chose a bramble because he was convenient. Do you hold your leaders, in church, work, and society, to the standard of Scripture? Pray for those in authority over you.

Finally, take comfort that God sees. Abimelech's crimes were hidden from earthly justice for a time, but not from God. Trust him to repay evil, and don't take revenge into your own hands.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from grasping for power.
- Ask him for the heart of the servant king.
- Pray for leaders who fear him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 32

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 222 · WEEK 32

Judges 11:1-12:15

Jephthah's vow; the Ephraimites

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 61 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 11:1-12:15. This reading includes the story of Jephthah, whose rash vow leads to tragedy, and a brief conflict with the Ephraimites. Read it slowly and with care. It is one of the hardest narratives in the book, and the text does not tell us how to feel about it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel is again oppressed, this time by the Ammonites. The elders of Gilead go to Jephthah, a mighty warrior who had been driven out by his half-brothers because his mother was a prostitute. They ask him to lead them. Jephthah negotiates, makes a speech in which he recounts Israel's history, and is empowered by the Spirit of the LORD. Then he makes a vow that will cost him dearly. The story reflects an Israel so far from the knowledge of God that even a judge, a man of faith in Hebrews 11, can act in ignorance and desperation. The chapter is a warning about the danger of vows made without thought.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Jephthah is the son of a prostitute, rejected by his brothers, and gathers "worthless fellows" around him (11:1-3).
2. The elders say, "Come and be our leader." Jephthah says, "Did you not hate me and drive me out of my father's house?" (11:6-7).
3. Jephthah recounts the history of Israel's journey to the Ammonite king, arguing that God, not Israel, took the land (11:12-28).
4. "Then the Spirit of the LORD was upon Jephthah" (11:29).

5. He vows: “If you will give the Ammonites into my hand, then whatever comes out from the doors of my house to meet me… shall be the LORD’s, and I will offer it up for a burnt offering” (11:30-31).
6. The LORD gives the victory, and his only child, a daughter, comes out to meet him with tambourines and dancing (11:34).
7. She says, “My father, you have opened your mouth to the LORD; do to me according to what has gone out of your mouth” (11:36).
8. The Ephraimites quarrel, and 42,000 are killed at the fords of the Jordan, identified by their failure to say “Shibboleth” (12:1-6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jephthah’s story starts with rejection. He is an outcast, driven away by his family, and he becomes a leader of a band of raiders. When the elders come crawling to him in trouble, he shows both pride and shrewdness. He extracts a promise that, if he wins, he will be their head. There is a note of dignity in this. Yet his speech to the Ammonite king shows real knowledge of Israel’s history. Jephthah knows the Scriptures. He argues from Numbers and Deuteronomy, and he says, “Let the LORD, the Judge, decide.” This is not an ignorant man.

And yet he makes the vow. After the Spirit of the LORD comes upon him, he makes a vow that nobody asked for. The vow assumes that God needs to be bargained with. “If you will give… then I will offer.” The Spirit had already come. The victory was already promised. The vow shows insecurity, a desire to buy what God had freely offered. The vow is a tragic confusion of grace and transaction.

The question of what happened to his daughter is debated. Some interpreters argue that Jephthah did offer her as a burnt sacrifice, and the narrative’s grief supports that. Others suggest that she was given to lifelong service at the sanctuary, unmarried, which also explains the two-month mourning of her virginity. The text is ambiguous, but the heaviness is clear. In any reading, a rash vow has cost two lives, a father’s hope and a daughter’s future. The law of Moses condemned human sacrifice (Leviticus 18:21; Deuteronomy 12:31), and it also provided ways to redeem a vow (Leviticus 27). Jephthah either did not know them or did not trust them. Ignorance of the word of God leads to disaster.

What is the reader to take from this? The book of Judges never presents Jephthah as a model. He is listed in Hebrews 11 among those who by faith conquered kingdoms, but that does not mean everything he did was right. Faith can coexist with great failure. The book of Judges is showing how deep the confusion is in Israel when God’s word is not known. “Everyone did what was right in his own eyes.” Even those with real faith are bent by their culture.

The story of the Ephraimites at the Jordan fords is another sign of decay. The tribes are fighting each other, and 42,000 die over wounded pride. The word “Shibboleth” has become a symbol for any test that separates insiders from outsiders. Israel has a civil war within a few years of victory. Without a king, without knowing the LORD, the unity of the nation is falling apart.

STEP 5

Connection

The law about vows is in Numbers 30, Leviticus 27, and Deuteronomy 23:21-23, and Ecclesiastes 5:2-5 warns against rash vows. The prohibition of child sacrifice is in Leviticus 18:21 and Deuteronomy 18:10. Jephthah is named in Hebrews 11:32 and 1 Samuel 12:11. The pattern of an outcast who rescues his people anticipates Joseph and David, and ultimately Christ, who was rejected by his own (John 1:11). Abraham’s willingness to offer Isaac (Genesis 22) contrasts with God’s provision of a substitute.

STEP 6

Application

First, be careful with promises to God. Do not bargain with him as though he needs persuasion. He has already given what is best in Christ. Consider whether you have made commitments in a rush of emotion that you now need to bring honestly to him.

Second, study God’s word so you are not led by guesswork. Jephthah’s tragedy came in part from not knowing, or not trusting, what God had said. Choose a book of the Bible to read slowly over the next month.

Third, grieve with the daughter. The text invites sorrow. Pray for those in your life who have suffered because of a leader’s foolishness, and ask God to bring justice and healing.

Finally, rejoice that God did not require a human sacrifice. Instead, he provided his own Son.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Pray for those who suffer from foolish vows and ignorance of God’s word.

Thank God that you do not need to bargain, because he gave his own Son.

Ask him to teach you to know him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 32

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 223 · WEEK 32

Judges 13:1-14:20

Samson's birth; his Philistine wife

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 45 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 13:1-14:20. The reading introduces Samson, the most famous and the most troubling of the judges. As you read, notice how the story starts with a promising birth and a faithful couple, and slowly turns into a man ruled by his appetites. Keep in mind that his strength is a gift of the Spirit and not of his muscles.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has done evil again, and this time the oppressor is the Philistines, who will remain a threat until the time of David. There is a significant difference from the earlier cycles. This time, Israel does not cry out to the LORD. The text does not mention any repentance. God acts on his own initiative. He sends the angel of the LORD to a barren woman in the tribe of Dan, the wife of Manoah, and announces the birth of a son who will begin to save Israel. The stories of Samson open with a miracle birth, but they will end in blindness and death. Samson is a figure of tragic gift: a man consecrated to God from the womb who lives like everyone else.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The people of Israel again did what was evil in the sight of the LORD, and the LORD gave them into the hand of the Philistines forty years" (13:1).
2. The angel of the LORD appears to Manoah's barren wife and says she will conceive a son who will be a Nazirite "from the womb" (13:3-5).
3. The boy is to have no razor on his head and not to drink wine, and he "shall begin to save Israel from the hand of the Philistines" (13:5).

4. Manoah prays for the angel to return, and the angel ascends in the flame of the altar (13:8-20).
5. Manoah says, "We shall surely die, for we have seen God," and his wife reasons that if the LORD wanted to kill them, he would not have accepted their offering (13:22-23).
6. "The boy grew, and the LORD blessed him. And the Spirit of the LORD began to stir him" (13:24-25).
7. Samson demands a Philistine wife: "Get her for me, for she is right in my eyes" (14:3).
8. The text says that this "was from the LORD, for he was seeking an opportunity against the Philistines" (14:4).
9. Samson kills a lion with his bare hands, poses a riddle, and loses his wedding bet through his wife's betrayal (14:5-20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening chapter is one of the most beautiful in the book. A barren woman, like Sarah, Rebekah, and Rachel, is visited by God. Like Hannah later and Elizabeth after her, she will bear a child through divine intervention. The pattern is familiar: God overcomes human inability to bring salvation. The angel's instructions emphasize that the boy is to be set apart from birth. The Nazirite vow, described in Numbers 6, included abstaining from wine, avoiding contact with the dead, and leaving the hair uncut. It was a visible sign of consecration.

Notice the contrast between Manoah and his wife. Manoah is fearful and cautious. His wife is perceptive and calm. When the angel ascends in the fire, Manoah despairs. His wife reasons from God's character: if he intended to destroy us, he would not have accepted our sacrifice or told us these things. Her theology is sound, and it is a model of how to reason from the grace of God. She understands that God's gifts are signs of his favor.

Then Samson grows up, and the Spirit begins to stir him, but the next scene is troubling. He sees a Philistine woman and demands, "Get her for me, for she is right in my eyes." This phrase is the key to the whole book. "Everyone did what was right in his own eyes." Samson is the embodiment of the age. The man consecrated to God is governed by what he sees. His parents object, and the text tells us they did not know that this was from the LORD, who was seeking an opportunity against the Philistines. This is a paradox: God uses Samson's sin to accomplish his purposes. It does not excuse Samson. It shows that God's plans are not thwarted by human weakness.

The lion episode reveals the source of his power: “the Spirit of the LORD rushed upon him.” His strength is not physical. It is a gift. Yet he does not tell his parents about the lion or the honey in its carcass, a hint that he has already violated his Nazirite vow by touching a carcass. His riddle at the wedding feast is built on a secret he cannot share, and he loses it to his wife’s tears. The story is a catalog of the ways a man can squander a gift.

Samson is a tragic figure, but he also points forward. His miraculous birth, his consecration, and his role as a deliverer anticipate Christ. But he is a shadow, not the substance. Where Samson indulged his appetites, Jesus resisted the tempter in the wilderness. Where Samson was blinded, Jesus gives sight to the blind. Where Samson finally pulled down a temple in death, Jesus’s death tore the veil of the temple and set people free.

STEP 5

Connection

The Nazirite vow is described in Numbers 6:1-21. The barren-mother pattern appears in Genesis 18, 25, 29, 1 Samuel 1, and Luke 1. The angel of the LORD who ascends in fire recalls Genesis 16 and Exodus 3. The Spirit rushing upon Samson is echoed in Judges 3:10, 6:34, and 11:29, and in 1 Samuel 10:6. Hebrews 11:32 includes Samson. Jesus’s birth, consecration, and victory over Satan contrast with Samson’s failures (Luke 1-4).

STEP 6

Application

First, let Manoah’s wife teach you to reason from God’s grace. When you are afraid, ask what God has already done. His gifts and promises are signs of his intention to bless.

Second, examine what is “right in your eyes.” Samson’s downfall began with what he saw. What do you look at, and what do you pursue because it looks good? Bring your desires before the Lord and ask for his wisdom.

Third, remember that your gifts are not your own. Samson’s strength came from the Spirit. Whatever abilities you have, thank God for them and use them for his purposes.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for gifts you did not earn.

Ask him to keep you from living by what is right in your own eyes.

Ask him for faithfulness in your calling.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 32

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 224 · WEEK 32

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you sang two psalms of God's power over the nations and followed the judges Gideon, Abimelech, Jephthah, and the opening of Samson's story. Rest today in the single truth that runs through all of it: God saves by his own strength, usually through weak instruments.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts."

ZECHARIAH 4:6

REST

Meditation

Zechariah 4:6 comes from a later prophet speaking to a discouraged remnant, but it sums up what this week's readings have been saying.

"Not by might." The word refers to an army or strength in numbers. Gideon began with 32,000 and ended with 300. God does not need a big force. He often deliberately reduces ours so that we cannot take credit.

"Nor by power." The second word refers to individual strength or ability. Samson was the strongest man in Israel, and his strength led to his ruin. Power in our hands is dangerous because it can lead us to trust ourselves.

"But by my Spirit." This is the center. God works through the Spirit, who rushed upon Gideon and stirred Samson. The Spirit is not a force we control but the presence of God himself, accomplishing what we cannot.

“Says the LORD of hosts.” The speaker is the commander of the armies of heaven. His word has the authority of the one who rules all.

For the Christian, this verse is a daily corrective. We are tempted to evaluate our usefulness by our abilities, our resources, or our results. The verse reminds us that God’s work is done by his Spirit, who lives in every believer. Our task is to depend, to obey, and to leave the results to him. Memorize the verse and carry it into whatever feels too big this week.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began with Psalm 46 and Psalm 76, two songs of Zion that celebrate God’s power over chaos and the nations. You heard the command, “Be still, and know that I am God.” Then you read the great cycle of judges. You followed Gideon from the winepress to the 300 and saw how a victory became a snare. You read about Abimelech, the bramble king, whose reign ended with a millstone. You read the sad story of Jephthah’s rash vow and the civil war with Ephraim. And you met Samson, born to a barren woman and consecrated from the womb, yet already living by what was right in his own eyes.

The week showed a pattern: God keeps using weak and flawed people, because his power does not depend on theirs.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where are you tempted to rely on your own strength? Gideon’s army was reduced so that Israel could not boast. Think of an area of life, such as your work, parenting, ministry, or relationships, where you feel pressure to produce results. What would it look like to depend on the Spirit instead?

How does the failure of the judges point you to Christ? Every judge was flawed. Gideon made an idol, Jephthah made a rash vow, and Samson followed his eyes. The book leaves us longing for a perfect deliverer. How does Jesus fulfill what they could only hint at? What does it mean to you that he is both the true Judge and the one who was judged in your place?

What “bramble” offers might be tempting you? Jotham’s parable warns that those who crave power or comfort are often not fit to lead. Are there voices or goals in your life that promise shade but are likely to burn? Who in your life models the humility of the olive tree and the vine?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for saving through weak and flawed people.

Admit that you cannot save yourself, and rest in Jesus, the perfect deliverer.

Rest in his strength today.

DAY 225 · WEEK 33

Judges 15:1-16:31

Samson's exploits; Delilah; his death

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 15:1-16:31. These chapters finish the story of Samson, from his revenge on the Philistines through Delilah and his death in the temple of Dagon. Read slowly through chapter 16, and watch for the quiet sentence in verse 20: "he did not know that the LORD had left him."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Samson's wedding has ended in betrayal, and his violence against the Philistines escalates. In the stories you read today, he burns their fields with foxes, kills a thousand men with a donkey's jawbone, carries off the gates of Gaza, and then falls in love with Delilah. The text is brutally honest about a man with enormous gifts and no self-control. Samson never leads Israel into freedom, and the Philistines are not defeated in his lifetime. But the story ends with a surprising prayer. The man who lived by his eyes is blinded, humbled, and finally turns to the LORD. His last act is a sacrifice that begins the work God promised.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Samson burns the Philistines' grain with three hundred foxes and torches (15:4-5).
2. The men of Judah, afraid of the Philistines, bind Samson and hand him over; the Spirit rushes upon him, and he kills a thousand with the jawbone of a donkey (15:9-15).
3. Thirsty, Samson cries out to the LORD, and God splits a hollow place so that water comes out (15:18-19).
4. He visits a prostitute in Gaza and carries off the city gates on his shoulders (16:1-3).
5. "He loved a woman in the Valley of Sorek, whose name was Delilah" (16:4).

6. Delilah pressures him day after day until "his soul was vexed to death," and he tells her the secret of his hair (16:16-17).

7. "He did not know that the LORD had left him" (16:20). The Philistines gouge out his eyes and set him to grind at the mill.

8. Samson prays, "O Lord GOD, please remember me and please strengthen me only this once," and pulls down the temple, killing more in his death than in his life (16:28-30).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Samson is a study in contradictions. He is the Spirit-empowered deliverer, and the Spirit comes on him again and again. And yet his life is marked by appetite, revenge, and carelessness. The text never excuses him. Chapter 15 shows his motives to be personal grudges: "As they did to me, so have I done to them." He is not fighting a holy war for Israel. He is settling scores. Even when he is thirsty and cries out to God after a great victory, his prayer includes the complaint, "Shall I now die of thirst?" God still answers him with water. The mercy of God is bigger than Samson's failings.

Chapter 16 tells the tragedy of Delilah. Samson goes to Gaza for a prostitute and then falls in love with a woman who is paid to betray him. The details of the story are almost comic, three times he lies about the secret of his strength and three times she tries it out. And yet he keeps flirting with danger. He is like a man playing with fire, convinced he will not be burned. When Delilah's nagging wears him down, he tells her everything. The cutting of his hair is not magic. It is the final break of a Nazirite vow that he had long been violating. The real loss is described in verse 20: "he did not know that the LORD had left him." This is one of the most chilling sentences in the Bible. He wakes up and says, "I will go out as at other times." He assumes the power will be there. But it is gone.

The consequences are severe. The Philistines gouge out his eyes. The man who followed his eyes into sin is now blind. They put him in bronze shackles to grind at the mill, like an animal. And they celebrate in the temple of Dagon, praising their god for delivering Samson into their hands. This is the lowest point, because the name of the LORD is being mocked.

But the story has one more turn. Samson's hair begins to grow. In the dark, he turns to prayer. The prayer is short, and it is the first time in the story he calls on God as "Lord GOD" with personal appeal, asking to be remembered. His request is for vengeance, but it is also for the vindication of God's name. God answers. Samson pushes the pillars, and the temple falls. "So the dead whom he killed at his death were more than those he had killed during his life."

Samson is not a model of holiness. But he is a sign of God's grace. Hebrews 11:32 lists him among those commended for faith, which suggests that his last prayer was a genuine act of trust. The same grace reaches the worst of us. His story also points to a greater one: a Savior who is delivered to the enemy, bound, mocked, and who by his death destroys the power of those who hold his people captive. Jesus did what Samson only pictured.

STEP 5

Connection

Samson's story fits the pattern of Judges' downward spiral. The Nazirite vow is in Numbers 6. The loss of the Spirit echoes Saul in 1 Samuel 16:14. The temple of Dagon appears again in 1 Samuel 5. Hebrews 11:32 includes Samson, and Matthew 27:35-44 shows Jesus mocked by his captors and conquering through death. Colossians 2:15 and Hebrews 2:14-15 describe Christ's defeat of the powers through death.

STEP 6

Application

Take the warning of verse 20 seriously. Spiritual drift is often not dramatic. It happens in small compromises that dull our sensitivity until we do not notice that God's presence has become faint. Ask yourself honestly: when did you last feel a sense of God's nearness? What may have been dimming it?

Second, guard your eyes and your heart. Decide on one specific boundary this week that will protect you from a recurring temptation.

Third, take hope from Samson's last prayer. No matter how far you have fallen, God hears the cry of a humbled heart. Return to him today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God where you are gifted yet careless.

Ask him to open your eyes to your own heart before the drift goes further.

Thank Jesus for remembering and saving you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 33

“O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption.”

PSALM 130:7

DAY 226 · WEEK 33

Psalm 130

Out of the depths I cry, hope in God's redeeming love

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 130 slowly. It is a Song of Ascents and one of the seven penitential psalms. It begins in the depths and ends with a hope for all Israel. Read it twice, once as a personal prayer of repentance and once as a word of encouragement to others.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the dark stories of the judges, this psalm is a breath of hope. It speaks out of the "depths" of sin and sorrow, and it finds its way upward by clinging to the character of God. The psalmist does not minimize his guilt. He says that if God marked iniquities, no one could stand. But with the LORD there is forgiveness, and that is why he is feared. For a people reading Judges, who cycle in rebellion and rescue, this psalm shows where the cycle can be broken: in a heart that waits on God's forgiveness and redeeming love. It is also the psalm Martin Luther loved most, and one that Christians have sung for centuries.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Out of the depths I cry to you, O LORD! O Lord, hear my voice!" (vv. 1-2).
2. "If you, O LORD, should mark iniquities, O Lord, who could stand?" (v. 3).
3. "But with you there is forgiveness, that you may be feared" (v. 4).
4. "I wait for the LORD, my soul waits, and in his word I hope" (v. 5).
5. The psalmist waits "more than watchmen for the morning" and repeats it for emphasis (v. 6).
6. The word "wait" occurs several times, and the whole psalm has the movement of hope.

7 “O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption” (v. 7).

8 “And he will redeem Israel from all his iniquities” (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a cry from “the depths,” a word that suggests deep water. The psalmist is drowning, not in an external threat but in his own sin. He does not pretend. He knows that if God kept a ledger of sins, no one could stand. This is not hyperbole. It is the honest conclusion of anyone who has seen their heart. Romans 3:23 says, “All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.” The psalmist’s rescue does not begin with a promise that he is better than he thinks. It begins with the character of God: “But with you there is forgiveness.”

Notice the surprising reason: “that you may be feared.” We might expect forgiveness to lead to relief or love, and it does. But here forgiveness leads to reverence. A God who forgives is more awesome than a God who merely punishes. Forgiveness shows that he is both holy enough to condemn and gracious enough to pardon. The proper response is awe, and not casual indifference. Those who think forgiveness is cheap have not understood what it cost.

The next verses describe waiting. The psalmist waits for the LORD, and he waits in the word. He does not simply hope in a vague sense. His hope rests on what God has said. Then he uses a vivid image: “more than watchmen for the morning.” A night watchman on the walls of a city looks for the dawn with intense longing. The first light means that the dangerous hours are over. The psalmist says his waiting is like that. He is sure the morning will come.

Then the psalm turns outward. The one who has found forgiveness cannot keep it private. “O Israel, hope in the LORD!” Personal experience leads to public testimony. The reasons given are “steadfast love” (the covenant faithfulness, hesed) and “plentiful redemption.” The word “plentiful” suggests that God’s supply of mercy is more than enough for the sins of his people. And the final verse is a promise: “he will redeem Israel from all his iniquities.” Not from some, but all.

For the Christian, this is the psalm of the cross. The “plentiful redemption” is purchased by the blood of Christ. “In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses, according to the riches of his grace” (Ephesians 1:7). The depths into which we sank were entered by Jesus himself, who cried out in the darkness so that we would not have to.

STEP 5

Connection

This is one of the seven penitential psalms (6, 32, 38, 51, 102, 130, 143). The theme of forgiveness appears in Exodus 34:6-7 and Psalm 103:8-12. The watchman image recalls Isaiah 21:11-12 and Habakkuk 2:1. Paul cites the language of redemption in Ephesians 1:7 and Titus 2:14. Luke 1:68-79 echoes the hope for Israel's redemption.

STEP 6

Application

Name your "depths" honestly. What sin, regret, or weight are you carrying? Pray verses 1-4 in your own words. Do not skip to the hope before you have said the truth.

Then practice the watchman's waiting. Choose one thing you are hoping for from God, and set aside five minutes a day this week to wait on him in his word. Read a short passage, and ask what it says about his character.

Finally, tell someone. The psalm moves from "I" to "Israel." Share one way God's forgiveness has changed you with a friend, a family member, or a member of your church.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry to God out of your own depths, saying what you need.
- Thank him that with him there is forgiveness.
- Wait for him in your own words, trusting his word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 33

"O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption."

PSALM 130:7

DAY 227 · WEEK 33

Psalm 40:1-10

He drew me out of the pit, waiting and the new song

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 40:1-10. The psalm moves from a testimony of patient waiting to a new song and then to a public declaration. Read it as the testimony of someone who has been rescued and cannot keep quiet. You will meet this psalm again in the book of Hebrews, where it is heard as the voice of Christ.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the despair of Samson and the confession of Psalm 130, this psalm is the answer that follows a long wait. David has been in a pit, and God has lifted him out. This is a psalm of testimony and gratitude. Its opening verses are some of the best-loved in the Psalter. In this unit, we read it as a response to the story of Judges: when God's people cry out, he answers, and a new song follows. In the weeks ahead you will encounter it again in Hebrews, and see how its deeper meaning points to Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I waited patiently for the LORD; he inclined to me and heard my cry" (v. 1).
2. "He drew me up from the pit of destruction, out of the miry bog, and set my feet upon a rock, making my steps secure" (v. 2).
3. "He put a new song in my mouth, a song of praise to our God" (v. 3).
4. "Many will see and fear, and put their trust in the LORD" (v. 3).
5. "Blessed is the man who makes the LORD his trust" (v. 4).
6. "Many, O LORD my God, are the wonders you have done, and your thoughts toward us" (v. 5).

7. “Sacrifice and offering you have not desired, but you have given me an open ear” (v. 6).
8. “I have told the glad news of deliverance in the great congregation; behold, I have not restrained my lips” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with the experience of waiting. “I waited patiently.” In Hebrew the phrase is intensive: “waiting, I waited.” It was a long season. The person who wrote this did not receive an instant answer. We often want God to rescue us quickly, and he may not. But the psalm says that in the waiting, he “inclined” to David and heard. The image is of someone bending down to hear a faint voice. God stoops to listen.

The pit is a vivid image of helplessness. The “miry bog” is a place where every effort to escape makes you sink deeper. David was unable to rescue himself. God lifted him out and set his feet on a rock. The contrast is physical: from sinking mud to solid stone. And then “making my steps secure.” The rescue is not only an escape but a new stability.

The new song is the natural response. God puts it in David’s mouth. The song is not a performance but a gift. And it has a purpose: “Many will see and fear, and put their trust in the LORD.” David’s testimony is meant to draw others in. A rescued person is a living witness.

Verses 6-8 are the center of the psalm. David says that sacrifice and offering were not the thing God ultimately desired. What he wanted was a hearing heart, an “open ear,” and a life of obedience from within. “I delight to do your will, O my God; your law is within my heart.” David’s gratitude is not expressed in religious activity but in wholehearted obedience. This does not abolish sacrifice. It places it in its proper context. Outward rituals without inward devotion are empty.

The last verses commit David to public testimony. He has not hidden God’s righteousness in his heart. He has told the great congregation about God’s faithfulness and salvation. A person rescued from a pit has something to say. In the book of Hebrews, the middle verses are heard in the voice of Christ, who came into the world to do the Father’s will. You will read that when you reach Hebrews 10. For now, rejoice that God hears, lifts, and gives a new song.

STEP 5

Connection

The pit imagery recalls Joseph in Genesis 37, and Jeremiah 38 and Jonah 2. The new song appears in Psalms 33:3, 96:1, 98:1, and Revelation 5:9. The priority of obedience over sacrifice is in 1 Samuel 15:22, Psalm 51:16-17, and Hosea 6:6. Hebrews 10:5-10 quotes verses 6-8 as the words of Christ. Romans 10:9-10 links heart faith with public confession.

STEP 6

Application

If you are in a season of waiting, take heart. Read verse 1 slowly. God bends down to hear. Bring a specific request to him today, and commit to waiting on him without a deadline.

If God has rescued you from something, write out your "new song." It might be a paragraph describing what he did. Share it with someone this week.

Finally, ask yourself where your obedience has become outward only. Pray verse 8, "I delight to do your will," and ask the Spirit to write God's law within your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for drawing you out of a pit, and name one.
- Ask him to teach you to wait patiently and delight in his will.
- Ask him to give you a new song and someone to tell of it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 33

"O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption."

PSALM 130:7

DAY 228 · WEEK 33

Judges 17:1-18:31

Micah's idol; the Danites, religion as private property

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 17:1-18:31. These chapters begin the long appendix to the book of Judges, which shows how deeply Israel has fallen. Watch for the repeated phrase, "In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes." Notice how religion becomes a personal convenience.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The stories of the judges are over, but the book is not. The last five chapters tell two stories that illustrate the moral and spiritual collapse of the nation. The first, which you read today, is about a man named Micah from the hill country of Ephraim, his stolen silver, his private shrine, and a wandering Levite who is hired as his priest. The tribe of Dan then passes through, steals the idol and the priest, and conquers a peaceful city. The two stories show religion without God, worship shaped to the worshiper's tastes, and a priesthood for hire. They are told with dry irony, and they explain why the book keeps saying that Israel needed a king.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Micah's mother has 1,100 pieces of silver stolen, and she pronounces a curse. When Micah confesses, she blesses him in the LORD's name (17:1-2).
2. She dedicates the silver to the LORD to make an idol, and Micah sets up a shrine with an ephod and household gods (17:3-5).
3. "In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes" (17:6).

4. A young Levite from Bethlehem, looking for a place to live, agrees to be Micah's priest for ten pieces of silver a year (17:7-12).
5. Micah says, "Now I know that the LORD will prosper me, because I have a Levite as priest" (17:13).
6. The tribe of Dan, looking for land, sends spies, who consult the Levite and are told, "Your journey is under the eye of the LORD" (18:5-6).
7. The Danites steal Micah's idols and persuade the Levite to come with them: "Is it better for you to be priest to the house of one man, or to be priest to a tribe?" (18:19).
8. They destroy the peaceful city of Laish, rename it Dan, and set up the idol for themselves (18:27-31).
9. The author notes that the idol was there "all the time that the house of God was at Shiloh" (18:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Micah story is a careful satire. It begins with a theft and a curse, and the thief is the man's own son. The mother then blesses him in the LORD's name and dedicates the silver to the LORD, and promptly uses part of it to make an idol. Everything is mixed up. They use the name of the LORD, but they ignore his law. They speak of dedication, but they violate the second commandment. The household is spiritually confused, and nobody notices.

Micah's shrine is a religion of convenience. He has his own ephod, his own household gods, and his own priest. He even ordains his son. When a Levite from Bethlehem wanders by, Micah hires him, believing that he now has God's favor secured: "Now I know that the LORD will prosper me." He thinks he can buy blessing. The Levite, a man who should have been serving at the tabernacle and teaching the law, takes the job for ten pieces of silver a year and a suit of clothes. The point is that even those whose calling is to teach God's word have drifted.

The Danites arrive and complete the picture. They seek an inheritance, not trusting God to give them the land he had allotted. They consult the Levite, who gives a vague blessing: "Your journey is under the eye of the LORD." It is exactly what they want to hear. Then they take Micah's idol and the priest. When Micah protests, they threaten him. The Levite goes with them gladly. He finds the offer of a tribe more attractive than a household. His loyalty is to his own advancement.

The conquest of Laish makes the point. They attack a quiet city with no allies, "a people quiet and unsuspecting," and burn it. They then set up the idol and appoint the priest. The narrator adds a quiet closing note: all this happened while God's house was at Shiloh. The true worship was available, and they ignored it.

The whole story shows religion as private property. Each person designs his own faith. What is right in his own eyes becomes the standard, and even the name of the LORD is attached to it. This is not an ancient problem. It is the habit of our day: faith shaped to personal taste, clergy chosen by what they offer, and worship tuned to what feels right. The corrective is the word of God and a true king. Only Christ is the true priest and king, who cannot be bought and who does not tell us only what we want to hear.

STEP 5

Connection

The second commandment is in Exodus 20:4-6. The Levites' calling is in Numbers 18 and Deuteronomy 33:8-10. Dan's later role as one of the places where Jeroboam set up a golden calf appears in 1 Kings 12:28-30. The "no king" refrain recurs in Judges 18:1, 19:1, and 21:25. Compare the false teachers who say what people want to hear in 2 Timothy 4:3-4. Christ as the true priest and king appears in Hebrews 7.

STEP 6

Application

Test your own faith for "Micah's shrine." Are there areas where you have designed God to suit your preferences, such as a convenient view of sin, a comfortable church, or a vague spirituality? Ask the Lord to correct them with his word.

Think about who shapes your beliefs. Do you listen to those who tell you what you want to hear, or to those who tell you the truth? Seek out one person who will speak honestly.

Finally, thank God for the true priest who cannot be hired and the true king who rules in righteousness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess where you have shaped God to your tastes.

Ask him to teach you to worship him as he is, in spirit and truth.

Thank Jesus, the true priest.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 33

“O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption.”

PSALM 130:7

DAY 229 · WEEK 33

Judges 19:1-21:25

The Levite's concubine; civil war, "no king in Israel"

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 83 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Judges 19:1-21:25. This is the most disturbing section of the Bible, and it is meant to be. Read it carefully and prayerfully. Do not rush. The story is not an endorsement of what happens but a portrait of moral collapse. Pay attention to how the story echoes the sin of Sodom and to the closing verse of the book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second appendix to Judges, and it shows how far Israel has fallen. A Levite's concubine is raped and killed in Gibeah, a city of Benjamin, and the Levite sends her body in pieces throughout Israel to summon the tribes. The nation gathers in outrage, and a civil war follows that nearly wipes out the tribe of Benjamin. Then Israel, horrified by its own actions, tries to fix the problem by more violence and deceit. The story has no heroes. At its close, the author repeats his summary of the age: "In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes." The book of Judges ends in darkness because it needs a king.

STEP 3

Observation

1. A Levite takes a concubine from Bethlehem, who goes back to her father's house, and the Levite goes to bring her back (19:1-3).
2. On the return journey, he refuses to lodge in Jebus, a foreign city, and chooses Gibeah, a city of Benjamin (19:11-15).
3. No one in Gibeah takes them in, until an old man from Ephraim offers hospitality (19:15-21).

4. Worthless men of the city surround the house and demand the Levite, as at Sodom, and the Levite sends out his concubine (19:22-25).
5. In the morning, the woman is found dead at the door, and the Levite cuts her body into twelve pieces and sends them throughout Israel (19:27-30).
6. All Israel assembles at Mizpah, and the tribe of Benjamin refuses to hand over the guilty men (20:1-13).
7. After a bloody civil war in which Israel loses tens of thousands in two defeats, Benjamin is almost destroyed, leaving 600 men (20:14-48).
8. Israel mourns, "Why has this happened in Israel, that today there should be one tribe lacking?" and then secures wives for the survivors by violence and deceit (21:1-23).
9. "In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes" (21:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The story is a descent into hell. The introduction is subtle: a Levite and his concubine, and a long trip made reluctantly. The Levite refuses to stay in a foreign city and chooses an Israelite one, assuming his own people will be safer. His assumption is exactly wrong. The scene at Gibeah deliberately echoes Genesis 19, where the men of Sodom demanded to abuse Lot's guests. The author wants us to see that Gibeah, a city in Israel, has become Sodom. The people of God have taken on the character of the nations.

The horror reaches its peak in the Levite's act of sending out his concubine. The text tells it without comment, and the lack of comment is the comment. No one comes out well. The Levite is a coward, the old man is willing to sacrifice his own daughter and the concubine, and the men of the city are monsters. Later, the Levite's account to the tribes is self-serving, leaving out his own role. The narrator's silence invites us to be shocked. This is what happens when a people live without the restraint of God's word.

The war that follows is complicated. Israel is right to demand justice, but the way they pursue it is flawed. They ask God, "Shall we go up?" and he says yes, but they lose twice, with great casualties. Only after weeping and fasting before the LORD do they win. The text shows a nation seeking God only in crisis, and acting mostly on emotion. The destruction of Benjamin is nearly complete. Then, in chapter 21, the people suddenly realize that they have nearly erased a tribe. They have sworn not to give their daughters to Benjamin, and they cannot fix it without another sin. They attack Jabesh-gilead and kidnap young women from Shiloh. Each solution produces a new crime. The vows, the violence, and the schemes are all expressions of a nation that has lost its moral compass.

The concluding verse is the book's thesis: no king, and everyone doing what is right in his own eyes. But note the quiet hope. Gibeah is Saul's hometown. Bethlehem is mentioned as the home of the Levite, and Bethlehem will be David's home. The book sets up the contrast between a king who fails and a king who shepherds. And behind both, the reader is meant to long for a king who is truly righteous.

Christians read this story as a call to see the depth of sin and the need for a Savior. If this is what human beings do when left to their own judgment, then law and good intentions are not enough. We need a new heart and a true king. The gospel is not a better idea. It is rescue from a disaster we cannot fix. Only Christ, who was himself handed over to wicked men, can heal what Judges 19-21 reveals.

STEP 5

Connection

The scene at Gibeah echoes Genesis 19 (Sodom). The cut body parts recall Saul's summons in 1 Samuel 11:7. Gibeah was Saul's hometown (1 Samuel 10:26). The refrain "no king" prepares for 1 Samuel 8. Hosea 9:9 and 10:9 refer to "the days of Gibeah" as a byword for corruption. Jesus, handed over to wicked men, is the true suffering king (Matthew 26-27). Romans 3:10-18 describes the universal reach of sin.

STEP 6

Application

Do not look away from this story. Let it increase your sense of what sin does and what Christ saves us from. Spend time in prayer for those who suffer sexual violence and abuse in our own day. Ask the Lord what you can do to protect the vulnerable, such as supporting a ministry, listening to someone's story, or speaking up.

Second, ask where "what is right in your own eyes" influences your decisions. Choose a recent decision and check it against Scripture. Was it guided by God's word or by your own reasoning?

Third, let the story deepen your longing for the true king. Pray, "Come, Lord Jesus," and mean it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Pray for those who suffer violence and betrayal.

Confess where you do what is right in your own eyes.

Pray for Christ's reign to be real in your life and in the church.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 33

"O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption."

PSALM 130:7

DAY 230 · WEEK 33

Ruth 1:1-2:23

Ruth's loyalty; arriving in Bethlehem; Boaz introduced

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ruth 1:1-2:23. After the darkness of Judges, the book of Ruth is a bright point of light. The story begins with famine and death, and ends with a field of barley and a kind landowner. Read it as a short story, paying attention to the characters and to the quiet working of God's providence.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The book of Ruth is set "in the days when the judges ruled." This is the same dark era, and yet the story is of ordinary faithfulness. A family from Bethlehem, whose name means "house of bread," leaves because of a famine and goes to Moab. There, the father and both sons die, leaving three widows. Naomi decides to return to Bethlehem, and her Moabite daughter-in-law Ruth refuses to leave her. The two women arrive in Bethlehem as the barley harvest begins. By chapter 2, Ruth is gleaning in the field of a man named Boaz. The narrator is quietly showing that even in the worst of times, God has not abandoned his people, and that he is working through unnoticed lives.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Elimelech, Naomi, and their two sons leave Bethlehem for Moab because of famine (1:1-2).
2. Elimelech dies, and the sons marry Moabite women, Orpah and Ruth, and then die too (1:3-5).
3. Naomi hears that "the LORD had visited his people and given them food" and decides to return (1:6-7).

4. Orpah turns back, but Ruth clings to Naomi: “Your people shall be my people, and your God my God” (1:14-17).
5. Naomi tells the women of Bethlehem, “Call me Mara, for the Almighty has dealt very bitterly with me” (1:20).
6. They arrive “at the beginning of barley harvest” (1:22).
7. Ruth goes to glean and “happened to come to the part of the field belonging to Boaz” (2:3).
8. Boaz says, “The LORD repay you for what you have done, and a full reward be given you by the LORD, the God of Israel, under whose wings you have come to take refuge” (2:12).
9. Naomi says Boaz is “one of our redeemers” (2:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book opens with sorrow. A family leaves the land of promise for the land of Moab, a nation with a bitter history with Israel. The move seems rational, since there is food in Moab, but it leads to loss. In ten years, Naomi loses her husband and both sons. She returns to Bethlehem with nothing, convinced that the LORD has turned against her. “The hand of the LORD has gone out against me.” Her grief is real, and the text does not scold her. But the narrator slips in a quiet word: Ruth is with her.

Ruth’s vow is among the most famous speeches in the Bible. She is a Moabite, an outsider, with every reason to go home. Naomi tells her twice to leave. Instead she says, “Where you go I will go, and where you lodge I will lodge. Your people shall be my people, and your God my God.” It is a statement of covenant commitment, not only to a mother-in-law but to the God of Israel. Ruth has chosen to take refuge under the wings of the LORD. Like Rahab, she is a Gentile who joins the people of God by faith. The contrast with Orpah is instructive. Orpah’s decision is not evil, but it is the choice of the familiar. Ruth leaps into the unknown.

The return to Bethlehem is accompanied by honest grief. Naomi says to call her “Mara,” bitter. She says she went away full and has returned empty. But she is wrong on one count: she has Ruth, and the harvest has begun. The narrator marks the timing: “at the beginning of barley harvest.” God is already providing.

Chapter 2 introduces Boaz through a series of coincidences. Ruth “happened” to come to Boaz’s field. This is the narrator’s way of saying that God’s providence is at work in ordinary events, without any miracle. Boaz is generous. He notices Ruth, protects her, tells her to drink from the workers’ water jars, and makes sure extra grain is left for her. He has heard of

her loyalty, and he asks that she be rewarded by the God "under whose wings you have come to take refuge." His blessing is also an unwitting prayer for himself, since he will become the answer to it.

Naomi's response is a turning point. When she hears that Ruth was in Boaz's field, her tone shifts: "Blessed be he by the LORD, whose kindness has not forsaken the living or the dead!" She sees that God has not forgotten her. And she identifies Boaz as one of their "redeemers," a close relative who has the right and duty to restore a family's fortunes. This is the hinge of the story. The word "redeemer" will carry the book to its conclusion and ultimately to Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Moab's history with Israel is in Genesis 19:30-38, Numbers 22-25, and Deuteronomy 23:3-6. Ruth's loyalty parallels Abraham's call in Genesis 12. The gleaning laws are in Leviticus 19:9-10 and 23:22. The "wings" image is in Psalm 91:4 and Psalm 36:7. The Redeemer language appears in Leviticus 25:25 and Isaiah 41:14. Ruth is named in Matthew 1:5. Bethlehem anticipates Micah 5:2 and Luke 2:4-7.

STEP 6

Application

First, if you are in a season that feels like Naomi's, empty or bitter, be honest with God, but watch for the signs of his provision. The barley harvest was already beginning. Write down three ways you have seen his kindness in the last month.

Second, learn from Ruth's loyalty. Is there a person in your life who needs someone to stay beside them? Choose one way to show loyal love this week.

Third, look for the "Boaz" in your community. Kind and generous people are signs of God's care. Thank one of them today.

Finally, remember that you too have come to take refuge under the wings of the LORD, and the one under whose wings you shelter is Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he works in quiet ways even in dark times.

Ask him to open your eyes to his provision when you feel empty.

Ask him to teach you to take refuge under his wings.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 33

"O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption."

PSALM 130:7

DAY 231 · WEEK 33

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you finished the story of Samson, sang two psalms of waiting and hope, walked through the terrible last chapters of Judges, and began the book of Ruth. Rest today in the single hope that runs through it all: with the LORD there is steadfast love and plentiful redemption.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption."

PSALM 130:7

REST

Meditation

Psalm 130:7 turns the week's darkness into hope. After the idols of Micah and the horrors of Gibeah, here is the word that tells us why God's people can keep going.

"O Israel, hope in the LORD!" This is a command and an invitation. The psalmist has been in the depths and has found his way up. Now he turns to the whole people and tells them to hope. Hope is not a feeling that arrives on its own. It is a decision to trust the one who has spoken.

"For with the LORD there is steadfast love." The Hebrew word is hesed, the covenant love that does not let go. It is the love Ruth showed to Naomi and the love God shows to his people. It does not depend on their performance. It is committed to them.

“And with him is plentiful redemption.” The word “plentiful” is a reminder that God’s supply is greater than our need. If your sin is great, his redemption is greater. The judges failed, and the people failed, but the redemption did not run out.

For the Christian, this verse points to Christ. “In him we have redemption through his blood” (Ephesians 1:7). The plentiful redemption has a name. Say the verse aloud, and carry it into any moment this week when you feel the weight of sin or the weariness of waiting. Hope in the LORD.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw both the lowest point of Israel’s history and the first light of recovery. You finished Samson’s story, with Delilah’s betrayal, the loss of his strength, and his last prayer. You sang Psalm 130, out of the depths, and Psalm 40, the testimony of one lifted from the pit. You read the stories of Micah’s private idol and the Danites’ theft, and you read the horror of Gibeah and the civil war that followed, ending with the line that explains it all: “In those days there was no king in Israel.” Then you turned to Ruth. You met a Moabite widow who clung to her mother-in-law and her mother-in-law’s God, a bitter Naomi who came home empty, and a generous Boaz in the barley field. The word “redeemer” appeared.

The week held a clear contrast: the nation of Israel did what was right in its own eyes, and a single woman chose to take refuge under the wings of the LORD.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where do you see yourself in the cycle of Judges this week? Think about the pattern: forgetting God, hitting trouble, crying out, being rescued, and drifting again. Where are you in that cycle right now? What would it look like to break the pattern with a deeper, daily dependence on God?

How does the “plentiful redemption” of Psalm 130 find its fullest meaning in Jesus? Judges ends with a nation that needs a true king and a redeemer. Ruth introduces a kinsman-redeemer who will rescue a family. How does Christ, the greater king and the greater redeemer, answer what Judges leaves unresolved? What does it mean for you that your sin is not too big for his redemption?

Who is your “Ruth” or “Naomi”? Think about the people who have shown steadfast loyalty to you, and the people who need it from you. Is there a person in your life who is bitter, empty, or alone? What is one way you could stay with them this coming week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his steadfast love and plentiful redemption.

Thank him that he never stopped working in the dark days.

Rest in him today.

DAY 232 · WEEK 34

Ruth 3:1-4:22

The kinsman-redeemer; redemption; the Davidic lineage

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ruth 3:1-4:22. The story reaches its climax at the threshing floor and the city gate. Watch how Boaz acts as a redeemer, and how the chapter ends with a genealogy. That list of names is the point of the whole book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The barley harvest is ending, and Naomi is thinking about Ruth's future. She devises a plan that is culturally daring: Ruth should go to the threshing floor at night and ask Boaz to act as the kinsman-redeemer. Boaz, who has already shown his generosity, is willing, but there is a closer relative who has the first right. Boaz goes to the city gate, the place of legal business, and settles the matter before ten elders. The story ends with a marriage, the birth of a son, and a genealogy that reaches to King David. For readers of Judges, this is a stunning turn: from "no king in Israel" to the line of the king.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Naomi says, "My daughter, should I not seek rest for you, that it may be well with you?" (3:1).
2. Ruth lies at Boaz's feet at night, and asks him to "spread your wings over your servant, for you are a redeemer" (3:9).
3. Boaz blesses her: "You have made your last kindness greater than the first" and calls her "a worthy woman" (3:10-11).
4. He tells her that there is a redeemer nearer than he, and promises to settle the matter that day (3:12-13).

5. At the gate, Boaz tells the nearer redeemer about the land of Elimelech, and the man says he will redeem it. When Boaz adds that he must also take Ruth, the man declines (4:1-6).
6. Boaz declares before the elders that he will redeem the property and marry Ruth "to perpetuate the name of the dead in his inheritance" (4:9-10).
7. The women say to Naomi, "Blessed be the LORD, who has not left you this day without a redeemer" (4:14).
8. The child Obed is born, and the book ends with a genealogy: Obed fathered Jesse, and Jesse fathered David (4:17-22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The scene at the threshing floor can be misunderstood by modern readers. Ruth's request, to "spread your wings over your servant," is a request for marriage and protection. The same word for "wings" was used by Boaz in chapter 2, when he prayed that Ruth would find refuge under the wings of the LORD. Now Ruth asks Boaz to be that refuge, and he is the answer to his own prayer. The scene is full of integrity. Boaz does not take advantage of the situation. He sends Ruth away before dawn to protect her reputation, and he deals with the legal question openly.

The core of the story is redemption. Under the law of Moses, a close relative could "redeem" a family member who had fallen into poverty by buying back land or marrying a widow to raise children in the dead man's name. The redeemer needed three things: he had to be a relative, he had to be able to pay, and he had to be willing. The nearer redeemer was a relative and was apparently able, but he was not willing when he learned the cost. Boaz is all three. He stands at the gate and takes on the burden of the family at personal cost.

Boaz's actions are a picture of Christ. He is a relative, close to those he redeems. He is able to pay the price. He is willing, even when it costs him. Jesus became our brother in flesh and blood (Hebrews 2:14-17) so that he could redeem us. He paid the price with his own blood (1 Peter 1:18-19), and he did so willingly. "For the joy that was set before him he endured the cross" (Hebrews 12:2). The story invites us to see ourselves in Ruth, a stranger who was brought in and given a name and a place.

The ending is a surprise. The women of Bethlehem celebrate with Naomi, and she who was empty is now full. The baby Obed is placed in her arms. And then the genealogy reveals the reason the story was preserved: Obed is the grandfather of David. The Moabite Ruth is the

great-grandmother of Israel's greatest king. And Matthew's Gospel will continue the list: David is the ancestor of Jesus Christ. The story that began in famine and death ends with the line of the Messiah.

The book of Judges ended with the cry for a king. Ruth does not answer it directly, but it provides the beginning of the answer. God is working, in obscure fields and city gates, through obedient and ordinary people, to bring about the king. Even in the days of the judges, God was preparing the way.

STEP 5

Connection

The kinsman-redeemer laws are in Leviticus 25:25-55 and Deuteronomy 25:5-10. The theme of redemption appears in Job 19:25, Isaiah 41-54, and Galatians 4:4-5. Ruth, a Moabite, is named in Matthew 1:5, and Rahab too. The genealogy of Perez, Judah's son, recalls Genesis 38 and 49:8-12. David's line leads to Christ in Luke 1:32 and Romans 1:3.

STEP 6

Application

First, receive Boaz as a picture of Christ. He is near, able, and willing. Consider what that means for the debts you cannot pay: guilt, shame, and failure. Say aloud, "I have a Redeemer."

Second, reflect on Boaz's integrity. In a situation where he could have taken advantage, he acted honorably and openly. Where do you face a similar temptation? Choose to act with integrity this week.

Third, take heart from the genealogy. God's work is often hidden in ordinary lives. The faithfulness of one widow, one landowner, and one baby changed history. Ask the Lord to use your small acts of obedience for purposes you may never see.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being a redeemer who is near, able, and willing.
- Thank God for bringing a stranger into the line of the king, as he brought you in.
- Ask him to make you faithful in ordinary things.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 34

“There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God.”

1 SAMUEL 2:2

DAY 233 · WEEK 34

Psalm 127; Psalm 128

Unless the LORD builds the house

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 127 and Psalm 128 together. They are Songs of Ascents, sung by pilgrims on the way to Jerusalem. Both are about the home. As you read, think of Ruth and Boaz, and of the house that God builds from unlikely beginnings.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the book of Ruth, these two psalms are a perfect pair. Both are short songs of the family, and both celebrate God's blessing on a household. Psalm 127 is attributed to Solomon, and it asserts that all human labor is vain unless the LORD is its builder. Psalm 128 describes the blessed family of the man who fears the LORD. Together, they answer the question raised by Judges and Ruth: what does a faithful household look like? It is not one that does what is right in its own eyes but one that depends on the LORD for its foundations.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Unless the LORD builds the house, those who build it labor in vain" (127:1).
2. "Unless the LORD watches over the city, the watchman stays awake in vain" (127:1).
3. "It is in vain that you rise up early and go late to rest, eating the bread of anxious toil; for he gives to his beloved sleep" (127:2).
4. "Behold, children are a heritage from the LORD, the fruit of the womb a reward" (127:3).
5. Children are "like arrows in the hand of a warrior" (127:4).
6. "Blessed is everyone who fears the LORD, who walks in his ways!" (128:1).
7. "You shall eat the fruit of the labor of your hands; you shall be blessed, and it shall be well with you" (128:2).

8. The wife is “like a fruitful vine” and the children “like olive shoots around your table” (128:3).

9. “May you see your children’s children! Peace be upon Israel!” (128:6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 127 begins with a challenge to human self-sufficiency. We build, guard, and work, and the psalm says that all of it is empty unless God is in it. This does not mean we should stop working. It means we should stop trusting our work as the thing that holds our lives together. A house built without God may look strong, but it stands on sand. A city guarded only by human watchfulness is vulnerable. The anxious toil that robs us of sleep is a sign that we have forgotten who builds the house.

The surprising line is verse 2: “for he gives to his beloved sleep.” The phrase has a double meaning. God gives sleep to those he loves, and the sleep itself is a gift, even a form of worship. When we lie down in peace, we declare that the world does not depend on us. This is a lesson that fits well with the rhythm of weekly rest in this plan. The one who built the world did not need our help and can run it while we sleep.

The psalm then turns to children, a “heritage from the LORD.” In an age that sometimes sees children as a burden or an accessory, the psalm says that they are a gift, a reward, and arrows in a warrior’s hand. The image of arrows suggests purpose and direction. Children are to be shaped and sent out. The phrase, “He shall not be put to shame when he speaks with his enemies in the gate,” suggests that a family with strong children is a secure family.

Psalm 128 follows with a picture of the blessed home. The man who fears the LORD and walks in his ways will eat the fruit of his labor. His wife will be like a fruitful vine in the heart of his house, and his children will be like olive shoots around his table. These are images of vitality and community. The family is gathered, nourished, and growing. The psalm does not promise that all believers will have this exact family or experience. It describes the blessing that flows from the fear of the LORD, which includes the quiet joys of home, work, and table.

The psalm ends with a prayer for the larger community: “The LORD bless you from Zion! May you see the prosperity of Jerusalem all the days of your life! May you see your children’s children!” The blessing of the family is tied to the blessing of the people of God. And Christians read this in light of the greater household that Christ has built, the church. Jesus said, “I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it” (Matthew 16:18). Unless the LORD builds the house, we labor in vain. And he is building it.

STEP 5

Connection

The “builder” language echoes Solomon’s building of the temple in 1 Kings 5-8 and Proverbs 24:3-4. The anxious toil theme is in Matthew 6:25-34. The fruitful vine and olive imagery appears in Deuteronomy 8:8, Psalm 52:8, and Hosea 14:5-7. The household blessing links to Ruth’s story and the birth of Obed. The church as a house is described in Ephesians 2:19-22 and 1 Peter 2:5.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself where you are laboring in vain. Is there a project, a plan, or a worry that you are carrying as though it all depended on you? Read Psalm 127:1-2 aloud and give it to the Lord, naming it specifically.

Practice receiving sleep as a gift. Tonight, as you lie down, pray, “Lord, you hold everything, and I rest in you.”

If you are a parent, thank God for your children as a gift. If you are not, pray for the families in your church and look for a way to support one. Everyone has a part in the household of God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess anxious toil, and name what you are working for.
- Ask God to give you sleep as a gift and to build what you cannot.
- Pray for the families around you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 34

“There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God.”

1 SAMUEL 2:2

DAY 234 · WEEK 34

Review and Reflection

Unit 8 review, Conquest & Settlement

Year 1 · Unit 8 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "But as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD."
>
> JOSHUA 24:15

REST

Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and reflection on what you have learned in Unit 8.

Begin by memorizing the verse above if you have not already. Joshua 24:15 comes at the end of a long speech, and the whole of Judges shows what happens when it is forgotten. Say it aloud several times. Notice three things.

First, "But as for me." The sentence begins with a contrast. Others may choose differently. The gods of the Amorites and the gods beyond the river are all available. Joshua does not pretend there are no options, and he does not wait to see what the crowd decides. He makes a personal commitment.

Second, "and my house." The commitment extends to the household. Joshua takes responsibility for the spiritual direction of those under his care. This does not mean he can force their faith, but he will lead, teach, and set an example. The failure of the generation after Joshua is the failure to pass this on.

Third, "we will serve the LORD." The verb is "serve," meaning worship and obey. It is not a vague spirituality but a covenant loyalty. And the one served has a name: the LORD, who rescued Israel from Egypt and gave them the land. Joshua will go on to say that the people cannot do this in their own strength. We cannot either. The strength to serve is given by Christ. Pray this verse over your home, your relationships, and your calling.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 8 you have traveled through Joshua, Judges, and Ruth, the story of Israel's entry into the land and the long, painful years that followed. The unit began with God's commission to Joshua and the promise of his presence. You met Rahab, a Canaanite woman who confessed that the LORD is God, hung a scarlet cord, and was brought into the line of the Messiah. You watched the priests step into the Jordan, and you saw twelve stones piled up as a memorial. You saw Jericho fall by faith and obedience, and Israel stumble at Ai because of Achan's hidden sin. You read about the Gibeonite deception, the day the sun stood still, and the northern campaign.

You then studied the distribution of the land: Caleb's faithfulness at eighty-five, the Levites whose inheritance was the LORD himself, the survey of the remaining territory, the cities of refuge that point to Christ our refuge, and the near-war over the altar that was settled by Phinehas's careful inquiry. You heard Joshua's farewell and the great call, "Choose this day whom you will serve," along with the sober reminder that no one is able to serve a holy God in his own strength.

Judges opened with the incomplete conquest and the generation that did not know the LORD. You followed the repeating cycle of sin, oppression, cry, and rescue through Othniel, Ehud, Deborah and Barak, Gideon, Abimelech, Jephthah, and Samson. You saw how each judge was flawed, and how the nation slid toward idolatry and violence. The last chapters showed a people doing what was right in their own eyes, with the refrain "no king in Israel." Then Ruth lit a lamp in the dark: a Moabite widow who took refuge under the wings of the LORD, and a redeemer named Boaz who became the great-grandfather of King David.

Along the way, the Psalms gave you words for every season: the sea fleeing in Psalm 114, God's testing in Psalm 66, your portion in Psalm 16, the shepherd of Psalm 23, the refuge of Psalm 46, the warrior-judge of Psalm 76, the depths of Psalm 130, the new song of Psalm 40, and the house built by the LORD in Psalms 127 and 128.

The message of the unit is that God keeps his promises even when his people do not. The rest he gives is partial and fragile, and it points forward to a better Joshua, a better king, and a better Redeemer.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does the conquest reveal about the holiness and justice of God?

Look back at Jericho, Achan, and the Gibeonites. The conquest was a judgment on nations whose sin had reached its full measure (Genesis 15:16), and it also showed that Israel itself was not exempt. Achan's sin brought judgment on Israel, and Rahab's faith brought rescue to a Canaanite. God's holiness is real, and his mercy reaches those who take refuge in him. Write a few sentences about how these chapters help you hold God's justice and mercy together. How does the cross, where judgment and mercy meet, bring this tension to its resolution?

What is the cycle in Judges, and how does it function as a mirror for our own hearts?

Recall the pattern: Israel did evil, God gave them into the hands of oppressors, they cried out, God raised up a deliverer, there was rest, and then they relapsed. The judges themselves were flawed, and the book ends in moral chaos. Look at your own life. Where do you see a similar pattern of forgetting, trouble, crying out, and rescue? How does the book make you long for a better deliverer? Write down how Christ breaks the cycle in a way the judges could not.

How does Rahab's story illustrate justification by faith?

Reread Joshua 2 and compare it with Hebrews 11:31 and James 2:25. Rahab was a Canaanite and a prostitute, outside the covenant, with no works to boast of. She heard what God had done, believed, and took refuge in the way of rescue he provided. The scarlet cord marked her house. She was saved by faith, and her actions showed her faith was real. Think about how her story anticipates the gospel. How does it clarify the relationship between faith, works, and the grace of God in Christ?

How does Boaz function as a kinsman-redeemer, and how does he point to Christ?

Return to Ruth 3-4. A redeemer had to be a relative, able to pay the price, and willing to do so. Boaz fulfilled all three. Jesus became our brother in flesh and blood, paid the price of his own life, and did so willingly, for the joy set before him. Consider your own story. What debts or burdens have you been unable to pay? Write a short prayer of thanks to Christ, your Redeemer, for what he has done on your behalf.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for keeping every promise and going before his people.

Confess where you have done what is right in your own eyes.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 9 · DAYS 235-301

The Davidic Covenant

1-2 Samuel, 1 Kings 1-11, Psalms I-II integrated

God establishes his kingdom through a king. The covenant with David and its eternal promise.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

The largest block. The psalms of David beside his story (32 and 51, 63, 34) and the royal and Zion psalms (2, 20, 21, 45, 72, 48, 84, 87, 101).

UNIT 9

In this unit

WEEK 34

235	1 Samuel 1:1-2:36	*Reading*
236	1 Samuel 3:1-4:22	*Reading*
237	Psalm 1	*Psalm*
238	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 35

239	Psalm 2	*Psalm*
240	1 Samuel 5:1-7:17	*Reading*
241	1 Samuel 8:1-10:27	*Reading*
242	1 Samuel 11:1-13:23	*Reading*
243	Psalm 3	*Psalm*
244	Psalm 4; Psalm 5	*Psalm*
245	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 36

246	Psalm 6	*Psalm*
247	1 Samuel 14:1-15:35	*Reading*
248	1 Samuel 16:1-17:58	*Reading*
249	1 Samuel 18:1-20:42	*Reading*
250	Psalm 7	*Psalm*
251	Psalm 11; Psalm 12	*Psalm*
252	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 37

253	Psalm 13; Psalm 14	*Psalm*
254	1 Samuel 21:1-23:29	*Reading*
255	1 Samuel 24:1-26:25	*Reading*
256	Psalm 18:1-30	*Psalm*

257	Psalm 18:31-50	*Psalm*
258	Psalm 54; Psalm 59	*Psalm*
259	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 38

260	Psalm 64; Psalm 70	*Psalm*
261	1 Samuel 27:1-31:13	*Reading*
262	2 Samuel 1:1-3:39	*Reading*
263	Psalm 20	*Psalm*
264	Psalm 21	*Psalm*
265	2 Samuel 4:1-6:23	*Reading*
266	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 39

267	2 Samuel 7:1-29	*Reading*
268	Psalm 22:1-21	*Psalm*
269	Psalm 24	*Psalm*
270	2 Samuel 8:1-10:19	*Reading*
271	2 Samuel 11:1-12:31	*Reading*
272	Psalm 32	*Psalm*
273	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 40

274	Psalm 51	*Psalm*
275	2 Samuel 13:1-14:33	*Reading*
276	2 Samuel 15:1-17:29	*Reading*
277	Psalm 63	*Psalm*
278	Psalm 61	*Psalm*
279	2 Samuel 18:1-19:43	*Reading*
280	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 41

281	2 Samuel 20:1-22:51	*Reading*

282	Psalm 34	*Psalm*
283	Psalm 56; Psalm 57	*Psalm*
284	Psalm 30	*Psalm*
285	Psalm 35	*Psalm*
286	Psalm 38; Psalm 39	*Psalm*
287	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*
WEEK 42		
288	2 Samuel 23:1-24:25	*Reading*
289	1 Kings 1:1-2:46	*Reading*
290	Psalm 45	*Psalm*
291	Psalm 72	*Psalm*
292	1 Kings 3:1-5:18	*Reading*
293	1 Kings 6:1-7:51	*Reading*
294	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*
WEEK 43		
295	1 Kings 8:1-66	*Reading*
296	Psalm 48	*Psalm*
297	Psalm 84	*Psalm*
298	Psalm 87	*Psalm*
299	Psalm 101	*Psalm*
300	1 Kings 9:1-11:43	*Reading*
301	Review and Reflection	*Review and Sabbath*

DAY 235 · WEEK 34

1 Samuel 1:1-2:36

Hannah's prayer; Samuel born and given; Eli's corrupt sons

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 1:1-2:36. A new book begins, and it starts with a barren woman at a sanctuary. Read Hannah's prayer in chapter 2 slowly, and notice how it looks far beyond her own situation.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The book of Judges ended with the words, "In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes." The books of Samuel pick up the story at that low point. The priesthood is corrupt, the nation is scattered, and the ark is at Shiloh. 1 and 2 Samuel were originally one book, and they tell how Israel moved from the judges to the monarchy, and how God chose David. The story begins with one woman's prayer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Elkanah has two wives. Peninnah has children, and Hannah, whom he loves, has none, and Peninnah provokes her (1:1-8).
2. Hannah prays in bitterness of soul and makes a vow: if God gives her a son, she will give him to the LORD all his life (1:10-11).
3. Eli the priest thinks she is drunk, then blesses her, and "her face was no longer sad" (1:12-18).
4. Samuel is born, and when he is weaned, Hannah brings him to Eli at Shiloh: "For this child I prayed" (1:20-28).
5. Hannah's song begins, "My heart exults in the LORD; my horn is exalted in the LORD" (2:1).

6. “There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God” (2:2).
7. “The LORD kills and brings to life… He raises up the poor from the dust” (2:6-8). The song ends with “his king” and “his anointed” (2:10).
8. Eli’s sons, Hophni and Phinehas, “were worthless men. They did not know the LORD” (2:12), and a man of God announces judgment on Eli’s house (2:27-36).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening scene is quiet and domestic, yet it sets the tone for the whole book. God works through the weak. Hannah is barren and humiliated. The priest misjudges her. The nation is corrupt. Yet from this pain comes the prophet who will anoint Israel’s kings. It echoes Sarah, Rebekah, and Rachel, the barren mothers of Genesis, and it shows that God’s plan often begins where human strength has run out.

Hannah’s prayer is honest and costly. She does not hide her bitterness. She pours out her soul before the LORD. And she vows to give back what she asks for. When Samuel is weaned, she keeps her vow, and she leaves her only son at the sanctuary. The gift is real, and it is received in joy: she worships rather than grieves.

Her song in chapter 2 is the theological center of the section, and it announces the theme of the whole book. The LORD reverses human expectation. The mighty are broken, the feeble gird on strength, the full hire themselves out for bread, the barren bear seven. “He raises up the poor from the dust.” The song ends by looking forward to “his king” and “his anointed.” Hannah does not yet know that Israel will have a king, but she already sees that God’s kingdom turns the world upside down.

Against this stands the failure of Eli’s house. His sons take the sacrificial meat by force and sleep with the women who serve at the tent. Eli rebukes them gently, but he does not restrain them. The prophecy against his house shows that God will not be mocked in his own sanctuary. He will raise up a faithful priest.

The chapter sets two houses side by side. One is a house of prayer and faith, and the other is a house of privilege and corruption. The LORD honors those who honor him, and those who despise him will be lightly esteemed.

STEP 5

Connection

Mary's Magnificat in Luke 1:46-55 echoes Hannah's song closely, with its themes of the mighty brought down and the lowly lifted up. Hannah is the first to speak of God's "anointed" (the Messiah) in the Bible. Jesus, like Samuel, grew in "favor with the LORD and also with man" (2:26; Luke 2:52). Paul says that "God chose what is foolish in the world to shame the wise" (1 Corinthians 1:27).

STEP 6

Application

Bring something you are bitter about to God honestly, as Hannah did.

Read Hannah's song aloud. Ask which line you most need to hear.

Think about what you have been given that you could dedicate back to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pray honestly about something you have been holding back from God.
- Thank him for lifting the poor from the dust.
- Ask him to help you give back to him what he has given.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 34

"There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God."

1 SAMUEL 2:2

DAY 236 · WEEK 34

1 Samuel 3:1-4:22

God calls Samuel; the ark captured; Ichabod

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 3:1-4:22. These chapters tell how God called Samuel and how the ark was lost in battle. Notice how the word of the LORD comes to a child and how Israel treats the ark as a charm.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The word of the LORD was rare in those days, and visions were not widespread (3:1). Samuel, still a boy, serves in the sanctuary under Eli. The scenes that follow show God breaking the silence, and then a terrible defeat when Israel goes to war against the Philistines. The chapters belong together: in the first, the word of God is heard, and in the second, it is ignored, with disastrous results.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The lamp of God had not yet gone out, and Samuel was lying down in the temple of the LORD where the ark was (3:3).
2. The LORD calls “Samuel!” three times, and Samuel thinks it is Eli (3:4-8).
3. Eli tells him to answer, “Speak, LORD, for your servant hears” (3:9).
4. God tells Samuel that he will judge Eli’s house forever, “because his sons were blaspheming God, and he did not restrain them” (3:13).
5. Eli says, “It is the LORD. Let him do what seems good to him” (3:18).
6. “And all Israel from Dan to Beersheba knew that Samuel was established as a prophet of the LORD” (3:20).

7. Israel is defeated by the Philistines and brings the ark of the covenant from Shiloh, and the Philistines hear the shout and are afraid (4:1-7).

8. The ark is captured, Hophni and Phinehas are killed, Eli falls and dies, and Phinehas' wife names her son Ichabod, "The glory has departed from Israel" (4:10-22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The call of Samuel is among the most loved stories in Scripture, and it carries a sharp lesson. "Samuel did not yet know the LORD, and the word of the LORD had not yet been revealed to him." He served in the sanctuary, but he had not yet been addressed by God. Religious activity is not the same as hearing God. The LORD takes the initiative, and he calls a child.

Eli's response is a mixture of failure and faithfulness. He was a poor father who let his sons go unchecked. Yet when Samuel is called, Eli tells him the right words, "Speak, LORD, for your servant hears." Even a flawed leader can point someone toward God. And when he hears the word of judgment, he accepts it humbly. There is something moving in his submission, though it does not erase his guilt.

Samuel's first prophetic task is heavy: to tell his master that judgment is coming. He is afraid. But Eli asks him to speak plainly, and he does. This is the first test of a prophet: to say what God says, even when it is hard.

Chapter 4 shows the cost of ignoring the word. Israel loses a battle, and instead of repenting, the elders decide to bring the ark, as though it were a lucky charm. "Let us bring the ark of the covenant of the LORD here from Shiloh, that it may come among us and save us from the power of our enemies." They treat God's presence as a tool. The Philistines are afraid, but God does not fight for people who use him. Israel is crushed, the ark is taken, and the corrupt priests die.

The name Ichabod captures the meaning: "The glory has departed." It is the lowest point in the story so far. But the God who is not bound to an object will soon show his power in Philistia.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, "Whoever is of God hears the words of God" (John 8:47), and "My sheep hear my voice" (John 10:27). James 1:22 calls us to be doers of the word. Jeremiah 7:12-14 points back to Shiloh as a warning not to trust in the temple. Hebrews 1:1-2 says that God, who spoke in many ways, has now spoken by his Son.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Samuel's prayer, "Speak, LORD, for your servant hears," before your next time in Scripture.

Ask whether you treat any religious object, place, or habit as a charm.

If someone has said a hard word to you from God's Word, consider listening with Eli's humility.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Pray, "Speak, LORD, your servant hears," and then listen for a moment.

Ask him to keep you from treating his presence as a tool.

Thank him for the Word made flesh.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 34

"There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God."

1 SAMUEL 2:2

DAY 237 · WEEK 34

Psalm 1

Blessed is the man who walks not in the counsel of the wicked

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 1. It is the doorway to the whole Psalter. Read it slowly, and notice the contrast between two ways of life.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 1 has no title and no named author, and it serves as the introduction to the Psalter. It places two ways in front of every reader: the way of the righteous and the way of the wicked. It begins with the word "blessed," the same word that opens many of the most important sections of Scripture. After the story of Eli's sons and Israel's failure, the psalm shows what a blessed life looks like.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed is the man who walks not in the counsel of the wicked, nor stands in the way of sinners, nor sits in the seat of scoffers" (v. 1).
2. "But his delight is in the law of the LORD, and on his law he meditates day and night" (v. 2).
3. "He is like a tree planted by streams of water that yields its fruit in its season, and its leaf does not wither" (v. 3).
4. "In all that he does, he prospers" (v. 3).
5. "The wicked are not so, but are like chaff that the wind drives away" (v. 4).
6. "Therefore the wicked will not stand in the judgment, nor sinners in the congregation of the righteous" (v. 5).
7. "For the LORD knows the way of the righteous" (v. 6).

8 “But the way of the wicked will perish” (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 1 uses three verbs in verse 1 for the downward slide of the wicked: walk, stand, sit. A person first walks with the wicked, then stands in their way, then settles in as one of them. The slide is gradual. The first step is to take their counsel. It starts with what we listen to.

The positive picture is a tree. The righteous person is rooted in God’s word. His delight is in the law of the LORD, and he meditates on it day and night. The word “meditates” means to mutter or murmur, to go over the words quietly again and again. It is the opposite of casual reading. The tree is planted by streams of water, and its roots go deep, so that it bears fruit in season and does not wither.

Verse 3 says, “In all that he does, he prospers.” This must be read carefully. It does not promise worldly success in every case. The psalms themselves show righteous people suffering. It describes the fruit of a rooted life, and it points to the ultimate outcome. A person planted by the water will be fruitful, even if the fruit is not always visible.

The wicked are like chaff, the dry, weightless husk that the wind blows away. They have no root and no substance. The contrast is between weight and lightness, depth and surface. Verse 6 gives the reason behind it all: “The LORD knows the way of the righteous.” This is covenant knowledge. He watches over them and cares for them. The way of the wicked perishes because it leads nowhere.

Psalm 1 sets the tone for everything that follows. The Psalter is the prayer book of those who delight in God’s word. The key is the law of the LORD, which at this point in the story is the book of Moses, and which will be fulfilled in the one who perfectly kept it.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the truly blessed man who never walked in the counsel of the wicked and who delighted in the Father’s will (John 4:34). Jeremiah 17:7-8 echoes the tree image, and Revelation 22:2 shows the tree of life by the river. Jesus said, “I am the vine; you are the branches” (John 15:5). Paul says that we are “rooted and grounded in love” (Ephesians 3:17), and “rooted and built up in him” (Colossians 2:7).

STEP 6

Application

Ask whose counsel you listen to most. Is there a voice you need to turn down?

Choose a short passage to meditate on throughout the day. Return to it often.

Thank God that he knows your way.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to be a tree planted by his streams.

Ask him to root you in his word and keep you from the counsel of the wicked.

Thank him that he knows your way.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 34

"There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God."

1 SAMUEL 2:2

DAY 238 · WEEK 34

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Samuel 2:2 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God."

1 SAMUEL 2:2

REST

Meditation

Hannah's prayer is one of the great statements of faith in the Bible, and this verse is its center. She says it after she has given up her only son, with a heart full of joy.

"There is none holy like the LORD." Holiness means being set apart, utterly distinct. There is no one who is like the LORD in purity, power, and goodness. This is a statement of worship. When we compare God to anyone or anything else, he is incomparable.

"For there is none besides you." It is a statement of exclusivity. There is no other god. The gods of the nations are nothing. The great problem of Israel in the days of the judges was that they forgot this. Hannah remembers.

"There is no rock like our God." A rock is a symbol of security, strength, and permanence. In a world of shifting sand, there is something solid. In the Song of Moses, God is called the Rock (Deuteronomy 32:4). Hannah takes it up in her own song. When everything else gives

way, he stands.

For the Christian, the verse is a joy and a confession. Jesus is the Holy One of God (Mark 1:24), and he is the cornerstone on which the church is built (Ephesians 2:20). He is the rock that does not move, and the one in whom all who trust find security. Say it in your own words today: There is no one like you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the books of Samuel. You read of Hannah's prayer and the birth of Samuel, and her song that proclaimed the God who raises the poor from the dust. You saw the corruption of Eli's sons and the word of judgment on his house. You read how God called the boy Samuel in the night and made him a prophet, and how Israel lost the ark in battle because they treated it as a charm. You began the Psalter with Psalm 1, the portrait of the blessed man who is like a tree planted by water. The week taught that God exalts the humble, that he speaks to those who listen, and that his presence cannot be used as a tool.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Hannah's prayer was honest, costly, and answered. What is one thing you need to bring honestly to God this week?

Israel treated the ark like a good luck charm. Where are you tempted to use religious things as a substitute for a living relationship with God?

Psalm 1 describes a person who delights in God's word and bears fruit. What would it take for you to be more like that tree, and where in your day could you begin?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that there is none holy like him.

Thank him for answering prayer and speaking to those who listen.

Rest in him today.

DAY 239 · WEEK 35

Psalm 2

Why do the nations rage?, the anointed Son

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 2. This is the second psalm of the Psalter, and one of the most important messianic psalms. Read it as a drama with four voices: the nations, the LORD, the king, and the psalmist.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 2 is a royal psalm, probably used at the coronation of a king in Jerusalem. It begins with nations in rebellion, moves to God's answer from heaven, and ends with a call to submit. Along with Psalm 1, it forms the introduction to the Psalter. Psalm 1 is about the righteous person, and Psalm 2 is about the righteous king. Placed here, at the start of the books of Samuel, it points ahead to the king God will establish.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain?" (v. 1).
2. "The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the LORD and against his anointed" (v. 2).
3. "Let us burst their bonds apart and cast away their cords from us" (v. 3).
4. "He who sits in the heavens laughs; the Lord holds them in derision" (v. 4).
5. "As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill" (v. 6).
6. "You are my Son; today I have begotten you" (v. 7).
7. "Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage, and the ends of the earth your possession" (v. 8).
8. "Kiss the Son, lest he be angry… Blessed are all who take refuge in him" (vv. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a question that exposes the folly of human rebellion: “Why do the nations rage?” The kings of the earth gather against the LORD and his anointed, saying, “Let us burst their bonds apart.” They see God’s rule as a prison. But their plotting is “in vain.” It is the oldest delusion: that we can throw off the rule of our Creator and be free.

God’s response is striking. He laughs. It is not the laughter of cruelty. It is the laughter of one who is secure. The nations’ rage cannot touch him. He sits in heaven, and then he speaks, and his word is terrifying: “I have set my King on Zion.” God’s answer to rebellion is a king.

In verse 7, the king speaks. “You are my Son; today I have begotten you.” In ancient Israel, the king was called God’s son at his enthronement, a way of saying that he ruled as God’s representative. The promise to David in 2 Samuel 7:14 is in view, and you will read it soon. But the words reach beyond any ordinary king. The ends of the earth are promised to this Son, and “you shall break them with a rod of iron.”

The psalm ends with an invitation. The kings are told to be wise, to serve the LORD with fear, to kiss the Son, to submit. The final line is a beatitude: “Blessed are all who take refuge in him.” It echoes the “blessed” of Psalm 1:1. The Psalter begins and ends the introduction with blessing.

For Israel, the king in Jerusalem was a sign. But as Israel’s kings failed one after another, the psalm began to be read as a promise of a king still to come, the Messiah, who would truly rule the nations.

STEP 5

Connection

The New Testament quotes Psalm 2 more than any other psalm. At Jesus’ baptism and transfiguration, the Father says, “You are my beloved Son” (Mark 1:11; 9:7). Acts 4:25-28 applies verses 1 and 2 to the plot against Jesus. Paul quotes verse 7 about the resurrection (Acts 13:33). Hebrews 1:5 and 5:5 use it of Christ’s sonship and priesthood. Revelation 2:27, 12:5, and 19:15 apply the rod of iron to his final victory.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you ever see God’s rule as a prison. Bring that to him honestly.

Take refuge in the Son. Name one fear, and place it in his hands.

Pray for leaders in your nation and for a spirit of humility among them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you do when the nations rage and plots seem to prosper.

Take refuge in the Son, and tell him so.

Ask him to teach you to rejoice with trembling.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 35

"But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head."

PSALM 3:3

DAY 240 · WEEK 35

1 Samuel 5:1-7:17

The ark in Philistia; its return; Samuel judges Israel

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 61 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 5:1-7:17. The ark, captured in chapter 4, now travels through Philistine cities and comes home. Then Samuel leads Israel in repentance. Notice who is in control throughout.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Philistines have captured the ark and taken it to the temple of Dagon in Ashdod. These chapters show what happens next. The ark is not a trophy. It is the throne of the LORD, and he defeats Dagon without an army. After seven months, the Philistines send it back with an offering. At Kiriath-jearim it rests for twenty years. Then Samuel calls Israel to turn from idols and leads them to a decisive victory at Mizpah.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The Philistines set the ark beside Dagon, and the next morning Dagon has fallen on his face before the ark (5:1-3).
2. The next morning, Dagon is on the ground again, with head and hands cut off (5:4).
3. The LORD afflicts the people of Ashdod, Gath, and Ekron with tumors, and they say, “The hand of his is heavy against us” (5:6-12).
4. The Philistine priests advise sending the ark back with a guilt offering, to test whether the LORD is responsible (6:1-9).
5. Two cows pull the cart straight to Beth-shemesh, “lowing as they went” (6:10-12).
6. Some of the men of Beth-shemesh look into the ark, and God strikes them. They say, “Who is able to stand before the LORD, this holy God?” (6:19-20).

7. Samuel says, “If you are returning to the LORD with all your heart, then put away the foreign gods” (7:3).

8. Samuel sets up a stone and calls it Ebenezer, saying, “Till now the LORD has helped us” (7:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The story of the ark in Philistia is told with a touch of dark humor. The god Dagon bows to the ark of the LORD, falls, and breaks. The Philistines suffer plagues. And the cows, who have never pulled a cart, walk straight to Israel with their calves left behind. The point is that the LORD does not need anyone’s help. He was not defeated at Aphek. He allowed Israel to be defeated, and he is still the God above all gods. The loss of the ark was not his defeat, but his judgment.

The lesson for Israel is double. First, God cannot be used. The Philistines learn that the ark cannot be treated as a prize. The men of Beth-shemesh learn that the ark cannot be treated casually, either. God’s holiness cuts both ways. The cry of the men of Beth-shemesh, “Who is able to stand before the LORD, this holy God?” is the question that the whole law raises.

The turning point is chapter 7. After twenty years, the people lament after the LORD. Samuel’s answer is simple and direct: if you are returning with all your heart, put away the foreign gods. Repentance is not just sorrow. It is the removal of idols. Israel obeys, they fast and confess at Mizpah, and when the Philistines attack, the LORD thunders from heaven and routs them. The people do nothing but cry out. God fights for them.

The stone Ebenezer, “stone of help,” is a monument of memory. “Till now the LORD has helped us.” It is a statement of gratitude and also of confidence about the future. If he has helped us thus far, he will not stop. The hymn “Come, Thou Fount” echoes this verse.

Samuel judges Israel throughout his life, going on a circuit each year. This is the beginning of a leader who is not a warrior but a man of prayer.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that “what agreement has the temple of God with idols?” (2 Corinthians 6:16). Jesus is greater than the ark; he is the true presence of God with us. John 1:14 says that the Word “dwelt” among us. Hebrews 12:28-29 calls God a consuming fire. 1 John 5:21 ends with, “Little children, keep yourselves from idols.”

STEP 6

Application

Name one “Ebenezer” in your own story, a place where you can say, “Till now the LORD has helped me.”

Ask whether there is a foreign god you need to put away: something you trust more than God.

Remember that God is not defeated when things seem to go wrong. He is working.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Put away a foreign god in your own life, by naming it before God.
- Return to him with all your heart, and say what that means today.
- Thank him for helping you thus far.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 35

“But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head.”

PSALM 3:3

DAY 241 · WEEK 35

1 Samuel 8:1-10:27

Israel demands a king; Saul anointed, God as true King

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 8:1-10:27. Israel asks for a king, and Saul is chosen. This is one of the most important turning points in the Old Testament. Read the elders' request, and listen for what it reveals about their hearts.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Samuel is old, and his sons are corrupt. The elders of Israel gather at Ramah and ask for a king "to judge us like all the nations." Samuel is displeased, and God tells him that the people have not rejected Samuel, but God. The following chapters describe how Saul, a young Benjaminite, is found, anointed in private by Samuel, and presented publicly at Mizpah. The monarchy begins, with a mixture of divine permission and human error.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The elders say, "Behold, you are old and your sons do not walk in your ways. Now appoint for us a king to judge us like all the nations" (8:5).
2. The LORD says, "They have not rejected you, but they have rejected me from being king over them" (8:7).
3. Samuel warns them what a king will take: sons, daughters, fields, and servants (8:10-18).
4. The people refuse to listen: "No! But there shall be a king over us, that we also may be like all the nations" (8:19-20).
5. Saul is described as "a handsome young man… from his shoulders upward he was taller than any of the people" (9:2).

6. Saul is searching for lost donkeys and finds Samuel, who anoints him privately (9:3-10:1).
7. The Spirit of God rushes on Saul, and he prophesies (10:6-13).
8. At Mizpah, Saul is chosen by lot but is found hiding among the baggage (10:17-24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The request for a king is not simply wrong. The law of Moses had anticipated it (Deuteronomy 17:14-20), and God had promised kings from Judah (Genesis 49:10). What is wrong is the reason. The elders want a king "like all the nations." Israel was supposed to be different. Their distinctiveness was that the LORD was their king. Wanting to be like the nations is a form of unbelief, a desire to trust in visible power instead of the invisible God.

Samuel's warning is a catalog of what human kings do: take. The word appears again and again. A king will take your sons for his army, your daughters for his kitchen, your best fields, your servants, and a tenth of your flocks. "And you shall be his slaves." It is a prophecy of Solomon's oppression and of every oppressive government. Yet the people say no, they will have a king. God gives them what they ask, and what they ask for will cost them.

Saul looks like a king. He is tall and handsome. But the narrative also shows his weaknesses. He is searching for lost donkeys, he is shy, and when he is chosen, he hides among the baggage. His humility is attractive, but it will turn into insecurity and fear of the people. At this stage, though, the Spirit of the LORD comes on him, and "God gave him another heart" (10:9). He begins well.

The chapters show a delicate balance. The monarchy is permitted, even blessed, and yet it is the fruit of a flawed motive. God works through human weakness. He will take Israel's misguided desire for a king and, in time, produce the king who is the Messiah. The people wanted a king like the nations. God will give them a king who is nothing like the nations.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the king who does not take but gives, who "came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many" (Mark 10:45). Pilate asked him, "Are you the King of the Jews?" (John 18:33), and he answered, "My kingdom is not of this world." The people shouted, "We have no king but Caesar" (John 19:15), echoing the elders' rejection of God. Revelation 19:16 shows him as King of kings.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you are tempted to follow what everyone else does instead of trusting God.

Think about who or what you rely on in place of God, and what it costs you.

Thank God that Jesus is a king who gives himself for his people.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have wanted to be like the nations.
- Ask him to keep you from trusting anything visible more than him.
- Thank Jesus, the king who serves.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 35

"But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head."

PSALM 3:3

DAY 242 · WEEK 35

1 Samuel 11:1-13:23

Saul's early success; his impatience; the kingdom taken

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 11:1-13:23. These chapters show the best and the worst of Saul. He wins a great victory, then he disobeys at Gilgal. Read chapter 13 slowly, and ask what Saul's real mistake was.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After Saul is chosen at Mizpah, he returns to farm in Gibeah. Then Nahash the Ammonite besieges Jabesh-gilead, and the Spirit of God comes powerfully on Saul. He leads Israel to victory, and the kingdom is renewed at Gilgal. In chapter 12, Samuel gives his farewell address. Then, in chapter 13, the Philistines gather a large army, and Saul faces a crisis that exposes his heart.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Nahash offers terms: the men of Jabesh may surrender if he can gouge out their right eyes (11:1-2).
2. "The Spirit of God rushed upon Saul when he heard these words, and his anger was greatly kindled" (11:6).
3. After the victory, Saul says, "Not a man shall be put to death this day, for today the LORD has worked salvation in Israel" (11:13).
4. In his farewell, Samuel says, "Far be it from me that I should sin against the LORD by ceasing to pray for you" (12:23).
5. Samuel also says, "The LORD will not forsake his people, for his great name's sake" (12:22).

6. Saul is told to wait seven days at Gilgal for Samuel to come and offer sacrifices (13:8).
7. When the people begin to scatter, Saul offers the burnt offering himself (13:9-10).
8. Samuel says, “You have done foolishly. You have not kept the command of the LORD your God… But now your kingdom shall not continue. The LORD has sought out a man after his own heart” (13:13-14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Saul’s first victory shows what a leader can be when the Spirit of God is upon him. He is angry at injustice, he acts decisively, and he is generous in victory. “Not a man shall be put to death this day, for today the LORD has worked salvation.” He gives God the credit. This is a king who understands that his power is on loan.

Samuel’s farewell speech is a model of pastoral integrity. He asks the people to testify against him if he has ever taken anything from them, and they say he has not. He then rebukes them for asking for a king, but with a promise: “Do not fear; you have done all this evil. Yet do not turn aside from following the LORD.” And he adds the lovely words, “I will not cease to pray for you.” A leader who loves his people prays for them even when they have wronged him.

Chapter 13 is the first sign of Saul’s downfall. The situation is grave: the Philistines have a huge army and Israel has no weapons. Saul waits seven days, as Samuel had told him. Then, as his men begin to leave, he offers the sacrifice himself, a task reserved for priests. It looks like a small thing. He was under pressure, and he meant well. But the narrative shows that it was a failure of trust. Saul was acting from fear of the people and the enemy, not from faith in God.

Samuel’s rebuke is severe. Saul’s kingdom will not continue. God has sought a man “after his own heart.” This phrase does not mean that David will be perfect, but that he will be a man whose heart is oriented toward God. The difference between Saul and David is not one of skill or sin, but of the posture of the heart.

The lesson is simple and searching: obedience is a matter of trust. Saul feared the people and tried to take control, and he lost the kingdom. Real leadership means waiting on God, even when everything seems to be falling apart.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus waited on the Father’s timing, as when he said, “My hour has not yet come” (John 2:4), and he trusted him in the garden: “Not my will, but yours, be done” (Luke 22:42). Paul quotes the phrase about David in Acts 13:22. The Hebrew phrase “a man after his own heart” finds

its fulfillment in the one who always did what pleased the Father (John 8:29). Peter says that the one who believes in him will not be put to shame (1 Peter 2:6).

STEP 6

Application

Think of a time you took matters into your own hands instead of waiting on God. What drove you?

Pray for your leaders as Samuel did, even if they have wronged you.

Ask the Lord to give you a heart oriented toward him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God for a heart after his own heart.
- Ask him to teach you to wait when everything says to act.
- Pray for those who lead you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 35

"But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head."

PSALM 3:3

DAY 243 · WEEK 35

Psalm 3

O LORD, how many are my foes, David's morning psalm

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 3. This is the first psalm in the Bible with a title that gives its setting: "A Psalm of David, when he fled from Absalom his son." It is a morning prayer of trust in the face of danger.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

David wrote this psalm during the worst crisis of his reign, when his son Absalom led a rebellion and David had to flee Jerusalem. You will read that story in 2 Samuel 15 to 18. The psalm is placed here at the start of the stories about David. It shows what kind of man he was: when he was most afraid, he prayed. It is a prayer for a day that began in danger.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, how many are my foes! Many are rising against me" (v. 1).
2. "Many are saying of me, There is no salvation for him in God" (v. 2).
3. "But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head" (v. 3).
4. "I cried aloud to the LORD, and he answered me from his holy hill" (v. 4).
5. "I lay down and slept; I woke again, for the LORD sustained me" (v. 5).
6. "I will not be afraid of many thousands of people who have set themselves against me all around" (v. 6).
7. "Arise, O LORD! Save me, O my God!" (v. 7).
8. "Salvation belongs to the LORD; your blessing be on your people!" (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a list of problems. David has many enemies, and they are saying he is finished. It is the voice of discouragement: "There is no salvation for him in God." The worst part of David's trouble is not the armies but the taunt that God has abandoned him. This is the hardest thing for believers in distress: not simply the pain, but the suspicion that God is not there.

Then comes the great "But you." David turns from the voices around him to the LORD. "But you, O LORD, are a shield about me." A shield protects on every side. He is also "my glory," meaning that even when David has lost his throne, his honor rests in God. And he is "the lifter of my head." A defeated man hangs his head. God lifts it.

The most surprising line is verse 5: "I lay down and slept." David is on the run from his own son, with an army in pursuit, and he sleeps. This is not carelessness. It is trust. He sleeps because "the LORD sustained me." The sleep is a sign that he has given his anxiety to God. It is one of the most practical pictures of faith in the Bible.

He is not naive about the danger. He asks God to arise and save, and he describes God striking his enemies' jaws. The psalm ends with a statement that is a creed in four words: "Salvation belongs to the LORD." David cannot save himself, and neither can anyone else.

Even in a bitter family conflict, with his own son against him, David prays, "Your blessing be on your people." He does not forget the nation. In his distress, he thinks of others.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus slept in a boat during a storm (Mark 4:38), showing the same trust. He too was betrayed by someone close, and he crossed the Kidron valley into a garden (John 18:1). Paul says, "We are afflicted in every way, but not crushed" (2 Corinthians 4:8). Hebrews 12:2 says that Jesus "for the joy that was set before him endured the cross." Revelation 7:10 declares, "Salvation belongs to our God."

STEP 6

Application

Pray this psalm tonight before you go to sleep, and entrust your worries to God.

Think about the voices that say there is no help for you in God. Answer them with "But you, O LORD."

Pray a blessing over your church and your nation.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is a shield about you, and tell him about those who rise against you.

Ask him to let you sleep in his care.

Bless his people in your own words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 35

"But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head."

PSALM 3:3

DAY 244 · WEEK 35

Psalm 4; Psalm 5

Evening and morning prayer, trust amid enemies

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 16 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 4 and Psalm 5. These are an evening prayer and a morning prayer, and they belong together. Notice the way each begins and how each ends with peace and protection.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 4 is traditionally read as an evening prayer, and Psalm 5 as a morning prayer. Both are attributed to David and both appear in the early part of the Psalter. They come directly after Psalm 3, so the first five psalms of David form a rhythm of day and night: morning in Psalm 3, evening in Psalm 4, and morning in Psalm 5. David teaches us to pray at the edges of the day.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Answer me when I call, O God of my righteousness! You have given me relief when I was in distress” (4:1).
2. “But know that the LORD has set apart the godly for himself; the LORD hears when I call to him” (4:3).
3. “Be angry, and do not sin; ponder in your own hearts on your beds, and be silent” (4:4).
4. “There are many who say, Who will show us some good? Lift up the light of your face upon us, O LORD!” (4:6).
5. “You have put more joy in my heart than they have when their grain and wine abound” (4:7).

6. “In peace I will both lie down and sleep; for you alone, O LORD, make me dwell in safety” (4:8).

7. “O LORD, in the morning you hear my voice; in the morning I prepare a sacrifice for you and watch” (5:3).

8. “But I, through the abundance of your steadfast love, will enter your house. I will bow down toward your holy temple in the fear of you” (5:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 4 is a prayer to be said before going to sleep. David is troubled, but he does not simply complain. He recalls that God has given him relief before. He tells his opponents to “ponder in your own hearts on your beds, and be silent.” The advice is good for anyone: before sleep, let your anger settle, and do not let it turn into sin. “Be angry, and do not sin” is one of the best pieces of advice in the Bible.

The psalm sets two kinds of happiness side by side. Many people say, “Who will show us some good?” They look for happiness in grain and wine, in material abundance. David asks for something different: “Lift up the light of your face upon us.” It is the blessing of Numbers 6, which you read in the last unit. And he says that God has put more joy in his heart than their abundance gives them. Joy that comes from God’s face is deeper than joy that comes from prosperity.

The last verse is among the most restful in the Psalter. “In peace I will both lie down and sleep; for you alone, O LORD, make me dwell in safety.” The “alone” is important. Safety is not from locks or armies, but from the LORD.

Psalm 5 turns to the morning. David begins his day with prayer: “In the morning you hear my voice; in the morning I prepare a sacrifice for you and watch.” The word “watch” suggests eager expectation. He lays out his prayer as a priest lays out the sacrifice, and then he looks to see how God will answer.

The psalm contrasts the wicked, whom God hates, with the righteous, who come into his house through his steadfast love. David enters by grace: “through the abundance of your steadfast love.” Our access to God does not rest on our goodness. He asks God to lead him in the way and make it straight. The psalm ends with the promise that God will bless the righteous and cover them “as with a shield.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus began his days in prayer (Mark 1:35), and he withdrew to pray at night (Luke 6:12). Paul quotes Psalm 4:4 in Ephesians 4:26: “Be angry and do not sin; do not let the sun go down on your anger.” Paul also says, “The peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts” (Philippians 4:7). Psalm 5:9 is quoted in Romans 3:13 as a description of human sinfulness.

STEP 6

Application

Make a point of praying at the beginning and end of your day, even briefly.

Before bed tonight, let go of any anger you are holding. Do not let the sun go down on it.

Prepare your morning prayer as a sacrifice, and then watch to see how God answers.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pray an evening prayer: give God today and what is unfinished.
- Ask him to put more joy in your heart than abundance can.
- Thank him that he alone makes you dwell in safety.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 35

“But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head.”

PSALM 3:3

DAY 245 · WEEK 35

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 3:3 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head."

PSALM 3:3

REST

Meditation

David wrote this verse while running from his own son. Everything he had was at risk, and yet he turned his eyes from the voices around him to the LORD.

"But you." These two words are the hinge of the verse. Around David were enemies, rumors, and a suspicion that God had left him. But he sets one word against them all. When your circumstances say one thing, you may answer with "But you."

"A shield about me." A shield is held up between the warrior and the arrow. David says the LORD is not only in front of him but all around him. There is no side on which he is exposed.

"My glory." David had lost his palace and his crown. If his honor depended on his position, he would have none. But his glory is God himself. No one can take that from him.

"The lifter of my head." The ashamed hang their heads, and the defeated look at the ground. God lifts the chin of his people and lets them look him in the face.

The Christian reads this verse through Christ. He is our shield (Ephesians 6:16), he is the glory of God (John 1:14), and he lifts us out of shame (Romans 10:11). Say it today whenever you feel surrounded.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read of Israel's request for a king and the rise and first failure of Saul. You saw the ark in Philistia, where Dagon fell and the LORD showed that he needs no one's help, and you read of the stone Ebenezer, "Till now the LORD has helped us." You read Samuel's warning about what kings take, and how Saul lost his kingdom at Gilgal because he feared the people more than he trusted God. In the Psalms you read the royal Psalm 2, where God answers rebellion by setting his King on Zion, and the prayers of David in Psalms 3 to 5 for morning and for evening. The week taught that God rules even when his people ask for the wrong thing, and that his anointed king is the only safe refuge.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Saul acted out of fear when he should have waited on God. Where are you tempted to act in your own strength this week instead of waiting?

Psalm 2 says, "Blessed are all who take refuge in him." How does Jesus, the Son and the anointed King, become a refuge for you in a specific worry?

Ebenezer means "Till now the LORD has helped us." Write down three ways he has helped you in the last year.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is a shield and the lifter of your head.

Thank him for the King he set on Zion.

Rest in the knowledge that he holds you.

DAY 246 · WEEK 36

Psalm 6

O LORD, rebuke me not in your anger, the first penitential psalm

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 6. This is the first of the seven traditional penitential psalms. Read it as the prayer of someone who is worn out by suffering and has nowhere else to turn.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 6 is a prayer of David, with the note "according to The Sheminith," probably a musical direction. Nothing in it tells us the exact crisis, and that is useful, because it lets many sufferers pray it. David is physically and emotionally exhausted, and he feels that God's anger is on him. The psalm moves from desperate pleading to a sudden confidence at the end.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, rebuke me not in your anger, nor discipline me in your wrath" (v. 1).
2. "Be gracious to me, O LORD, for I am languishing; heal me, O LORD, for my bones are troubled" (v. 2).
3. "My soul also is greatly troubled. But you, O LORD, how long?" (v. 3).
4. "Turn, O LORD, deliver my life; save me for the sake of your steadfast love" (v. 4).
5. "For in death there is no remembrance of you; in Sheol who will give you praise?" (v. 5).
6. "I am weary with my moaning; every night I flood my bed with tears; I drench my couch with my weeping" (v. 6).
7. "Depart from me, all you workers of evil, for the LORD has heard the sound of my weeping" (v. 8).
8. "The LORD has heard my plea; the LORD accepts my prayer" (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This psalm holds nothing back. David is weak, his bones are shaking, and his nights are given over to tears. He asks God not to rebuke him in anger. He does not claim to be innocent. He knows that suffering may be connected to sin, and he asks for mercy rather than strict justice. The ground of his appeal is not his own goodness but God's "steadfast love," the covenant word that appears again and again in the Psalms.

The question "How long?" is the cry of the sufferer in many psalms. It is not rebellion. It is an honest question brought to God. Believers in the Bible are allowed to ask it. The Bible does not require us to hide our exhaustion behind pious language.

Verse 5 is an argument. David says that the dead cannot praise God, so why let him die? At this point in the story of Scripture, the hope of resurrection is not yet fully revealed, and David's view of death is dark. The argument is that God's glory is served by keeping his servant alive to praise him. Later revelation will show that death is not the end for those in God's hands.

The turn comes without warning. In verse 8, the tone changes: "Depart from me, all you workers of evil, for the LORD has heard the sound of my weeping." Nothing in David's circumstances has changed. What changed is that he has prayed, and he is sure he has been heard. He says it three times: God has heard my weeping, my plea, my prayer.

The psalm teaches that tears are a form of prayer, and that God hears them. It also teaches that we may leave our suffering with God and trust him with the outcome, even before we see it.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, "My soul is very sorrowful, even to death" (Matthew 26:38), and "In the days of his flesh, Jesus offered up prayers and supplications, with loud cries and tears" (Hebrews 5:7). Jesus took on our weakness. John 12:27 echoes verse 3: "Now is my soul troubled." Revelation 21:4 promises that God will wipe away every tear.

STEP 6

Application

Bring your exhaustion to God without dressing it up. Tell him how long it has been.

Ask for mercy based on his steadfast love, not on your record.

Thank him that he hears the sound of your weeping.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God honestly how weary you are.
- Ask him to be gracious to you for the sake of his steadfast love.
- Thank Jesus for weeping and praying in the same way.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 36

“Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart.”

1 SAMUEL 16:7

DAY 247 · WEEK 36

1 Samuel 14:1-15:35

Jonathan's faith; Saul's foolishness; Saul rejected

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 82 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 14:1-15:35. Chapter 14 shows Jonathan's faith and Saul's rash vow. Chapter 15 records Saul's final rejection. Pay close attention to Samuel's words in 15:22-23.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel is still under Philistine pressure. Jonathan, Saul's son, takes the initiative against a Philistine outpost, trusting that the LORD can save by many or by few. Later, God commands Saul through Samuel to destroy the Amalekites, who had attacked Israel in the wilderness. Saul's partial obedience is the failure that ends his dynasty. These chapters mark the turning of the kingdom from Saul toward David.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Jonathan says to his armor-bearer, "It may be that the LORD will work for us, for nothing can hinder the LORD from saving by many or by few" (14:6).
2. Saul makes a rash oath that no one may eat before evening, and Jonathan, who did not hear it, eats honey (14:24-27).
3. The people ransom Jonathan, and he is not put to death (14:45).
4. The LORD tells Saul to strike Amalek and devote all that they have to destruction (15:1-3).
5. Saul spares King Agag and the best of the sheep and oxen (15:9).
6. Saul says, "I have performed the commandment of the LORD," and Samuel answers, "What then is this bleating of the sheep in my ears?" (15:13-14).
7. "To obey is better than sacrifice, and to listen than the fat of rams" (15:22).

8 “The LORD has rejected you from being king over Israel” (15:26). And “the Glory of Israel will not lie or have regret” (15:29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jonathan is a bright figure in a dark story. He and his armor-bearer climb a cliff against a garrison, and his words show a faith that does not depend on numbers: “Nothing can hinder the LORD from saving by many or by few.” The LORD gives a great victory. Jonathan’s faith contrasts with his father’s, who stays under a pomegranate tree and then binds the army with a foolish oath. Saul’s religion is concerned with rules and ceremony, but his heart does not trust God. The oath nearly costs Jonathan his life.

Chapter 15 is the decisive moment. The command against Amalek is a hard one, part of the judgment on a people whose long violence had been judged by God. Saul obeys in part. He spares the king and the best animals, and he says it is to sacrifice them to the LORD. When Samuel confronts him, Saul first claims he obeyed, then blames the people, then offers religious reasons.

Samuel’s reply is one of the great sentences of the Bible: “Has the LORD as great delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices, as in obeying the voice of the LORD? Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice.” God is not looking for religious performance but for a surrendered heart. Rebellion is as the sin of divination, and presumption is as iniquity and idolatry.

Saul’s confession is shallow. He says, “I have sinned,” but he immediately asks Samuel to honor him before the elders. He is more worried about his reputation than about his sin. Repentance that seeks to keep the appearance of standing is not true repentance.

The chapter ends with Samuel mourning for Saul, and “the LORD regretted that he had made Saul king.” The word “regret” here speaks of sorrow and a change of course, not of God being surprised. Verse 29 insists that God does not change his mind like a man. His purposes stand.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus quotes Hosea 6:6 twice, “I desire mercy, and not sacrifice” (Matthew 9:13; 12:7), in the same spirit as Samuel. Hebrews 10:5-10 says that Christ came to do God’s will, where sacrifices could not satisfy. Jesus was “obedient to the point of death” (Philippians 2:8), succeeding where Saul failed. John 14:15: “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.”

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you offer God religious activity instead of obedience.

Look at your last confession of sin. Was it about the sin, or about how you look?

Thank Jesus that he obeyed fully, and ask for a listening heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have offered God less than your heart.
- Ask for the faith of Jonathan, who believed nothing can hinder God.
- Thank Christ for his perfect obedience.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 36

“Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart.”

1 SAMUEL 16:7

DAY 248 · WEEK 36

1 Samuel 16:1-17:58

David anointed; Goliath, the shepherd-king

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 74 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 16:1-17:58. God chooses David, and David defeats Goliath. Read slowly, and notice what each side says about who will win and why.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After Saul's rejection, God sends Samuel to Bethlehem to anoint one of Jesse's sons as king. The chosen one is the youngest, a shepherd. David enters Saul's service as a musician, and then, in the valley of Elah, faces the Philistine champion Goliath when the whole army of Israel is paralyzed with fear. These chapters introduce the central human figure of the Old Testament narrative.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God tells Samuel, "Fill your horn with oil, and go. I will send you to Jesse the Bethlehemite, for I have provided for myself a king among his sons" (16:1).
2. "Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart" (16:7).
3. David is brought in from the sheep, "ruddy, with beautiful eyes and handsome", and the LORD says, "Arise, anoint him, for this is he" (16:12).
4. "The Spirit of the LORD rushed upon David from that day forward" (16:13), while the Spirit departs from Saul (16:14).
5. Goliath, who stood about nine feet tall, taunts Israel for forty days (17:4, 16).
6. David says, "Who is this uncircumcised Philistine, that he should defy the armies of the living God?" (17:26).
7. David refuses Saul's armor and takes five smooth stones and his sling (17:38-40).

8 “You come to me with a sword and with a spear and with a javelin, but I come to you in the name of the LORD of hosts… that all the earth may know that there is a God in Israel” (17:45-46).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The story of David’s anointing begins with a reversal of expectations. Samuel looks at Eliab, the tall oldest son, and thinks, “Surely the LORD’s anointed is before him.” But the LORD says, “Do not look on his appearance… For the LORD sees not as man sees.” This echoes the story of Saul, who looked the part and failed. God chooses the youngest, the one who was left with the sheep. It is a repeated pattern in the Bible: Isaac over Ishmael, Jacob over Esau, Joseph, Moses, and now David.

The Spirit’s movement is dramatic. He rushes on David and leaves Saul. Saul is now troubled by a harmful spirit, and David’s music soothes him. The king who has been rejected receives comfort from the one who will replace him.

The Goliath narrative is often read as a lesson in courage, but its real theme is who fights for Israel. The whole army, Saul included, sees Goliath’s size and trembles. David sees Goliath’s defiance of God. For David the question is not whether Goliath is big, but whether the living God is big enough. He has fought lions and bears, and he credits the LORD with those victories.

David’s declaration before the battle is the heart of the chapter. “The battle is the LORD’s.” He does not rely on Saul’s armor or on conventional weapons. He wants the world to know that God can save without sword or spear. The victory is not just David’s. It is for all Israel, a public sign that there is a God in Israel.

There is a deeper pattern. David stands alone as a representative for the people. If he wins, they win. If he loses, they are slaves. The people share in the victory of their champion without lifting a sword.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the greater David: born in Bethlehem, a shepherd, and the anointed King (Micah 5:2; John 10:11). He is the champion who fights in our place, defeating sin, death, and the devil (Colossians 2:15; Hebrews 2:14-15). The victory is ours without our having lifted a sword. Paul says, “God chose what is weak in the world to shame the strong” (1 Corinthians 1:27).

STEP 6

Application

Ask what your “Goliath” is, the thing that has been mocking you for forty days.

Remember that Christ has already fought and won. Stand in his victory.

Ask the Lord to teach you to see people as he sees them, by the heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to teach you to see as he sees, and to trust him in the battle you face.
- Thank Jesus, your champion, who defeated sin and death.
- Name a giant in your life and give it to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 36

“Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart.”

1 SAMUEL 16:7

DAY 249 · WEEK 36

1 Samuel 18:1-20:42

David and Jonathan; Saul's jealousy; covenant friendship

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 94 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 18:1-20:42. These chapters show David's rise, Saul's jealousy, and the friendship of Jonathan and David. Notice how David responds to being hunted.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the victory over Goliath, David becomes a leading figure in Saul's army. The women sing, "Saul has struck down his thousands, and David his ten thousands," and jealousy takes root in the king's heart. Saul tries several times to kill David. Jonathan, Saul's son and heir, becomes David's closest friend and risks his own father's anger to protect him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The soul of Jonathan was knit to the soul of David, and Jonathan loved him as his own soul" (18:1).
2. Jonathan makes a covenant with David and gives him his robe, armor, sword, bow, and belt (18:3-4).
3. The women's song makes Saul angry, and "Saul eyed David from that day on" (18:7-9).
4. Saul twice hurls a spear at David, and "Saul was afraid of David, because the LORD was with him" (18:11-12).
5. Saul offers his daughters Merab and Michal, hoping the Philistines will kill David (18:17-27).
6. Michal helps David escape through a window (19:11-17).
7. Jonathan says to David, "Whatever you say, I will do for you" (20:4), and they renew their covenant (20:16-17).

8. Jonathan shoots arrows as a signal, and David and Jonathan weep together as they part (20:35-42).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Saul's jealousy is the central tragedy of these chapters. He had been a victorious king, and now he cannot bear to hear another man praised. The spirit that began with envy ends in murder. It illustrates how sin grows: a small resentment, left unchecked, becomes a consuming obsession. Saul even sees that the LORD is with David and that he himself has been abandoned, yet he fights against God's chosen.

David's behavior in the face of this is notable. He plays the harp, serves faithfully, and does not take revenge. "David behaved wisely in all his undertakings, for the LORD was with him." He does not defend himself with a plot to take the throne. He trusts the promise that God made through Samuel.

The friendship of Jonathan and David is among the most moving in Scripture. Jonathan is the king's heir, and David is the one who will take the throne from his house. A less godly man would have seen David as a rival. Jonathan sees him as the LORD's anointed. He hands over his robe and his armor, a symbolic transfer of his claim to the throne. He says later that he knows David will be king (23:17). He chooses loyalty to God's plan over personal ambition.

The covenant between the two friends is renewed in chapter 20, and the scene of their parting is full of grief. Each man is faithful to the other, and yet they must separate. Jonathan will remain with his father, and David will become a fugitive.

Faithful friendship, in this story, is a gift from God and a refuge in time of trouble. Jonathan protects David at risk to himself, and speaks the truth to his father even when it brings danger.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, "Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends" (John 15:13). Jonathan gave up his claim to the throne for David, but Christ laid down his own life for his people. John 15:15 says, "I have called you friends." Like David, Jesus was hated without cause (John 15:25) and hunted by those who envied him (Mark 15:10).

STEP 6

Application

Examine your heart for jealousy. Who do you resent because they are praised?

Give thanks for a friend who has been loyal to you, and tell them.

Ask God to make you a Jonathan, a person who puts his purposes above your own advancement.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to guard your heart against envy.
- Ask him to give you Jonathan's loyalty and David's patience.
- Thank Jesus for calling you his friend.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 36

"Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart."

1 SAMUEL 16:7

DAY 250 · WEEK 36

Psalm 7

O LORD my God, in you do I take refuge

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 7. David prays when he has been falsely accused. Notice how he asks God to judge him, and how he trusts the Judge of all the earth.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The title reads, “A Shiggaion of David, which he sang to the LORD concerning the words of Cush, a Benjaminite.” We do not know who Cush was, but the setting is likely during the years when Saul, a Benjaminite, was pursuing David on false charges. The psalm is a cry for vindication from a man who has been slandered. It is placed here, right after the reading about Saul’s pursuit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “O LORD my God, in you do I take refuge; save me from all my pursuers and deliver me” (v. 1).
2. “O LORD my God, if I have done this, if there is wrong in my hands… then let the enemy pursue my soul and overtake it” (vv. 3-5).
3. “Arise, O LORD, in your anger… awake for me; you have appointed a judgment” (v. 6).
4. “God is a righteous judge, and a God who feels indignation every day” (v. 11).
5. “Behold, the wicked man conceives evil and is pregnant with mischief and gives birth to lies” (v. 14).
6. “He makes a pit, digging it out, and falls into the hole that he has made” (v. 15).
7. “His mischief returns upon his own head, and on his own skull his violence descends” (v. 16).

8 “I will give to the LORD the thanks due to his righteousness, and sing praise to the name of the LORD, the Most High” (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David’s prayer here is bold. He asks God to examine him, and says that if he has done what his enemies say, then they may overtake him. This is not pride. It is a clear conscience before God on this particular charge. He is not claiming to be sinless, but he is saying that on this issue, he is innocent.

His great appeal is to God as judge. “God is a righteous judge.” When we are slandered, we are often tempted to take revenge or to defend ourselves at all costs. David takes the better way. He brings the case to the highest court and asks the Judge to rule. It is an act of trust, and it frees him from the need to retaliate. We will see this in his own behavior when he spares Saul’s life in the next chapters.

The image in verses 14 to 16 is memorable. The wicked person conceives, is pregnant with evil, and gives birth to lies. Evil has a life cycle. The person digs a pit for others, and falls into it himself. The universe has a moral structure, and sin often brings its own consequences. It is a warning to the wicked and a comfort to the wronged.

The psalm begins with refuge and ends with praise. The pattern is typical: David brings his case, rests it with God, and moves to thanksgiving before he has seen the verdict. The title of “Most High” for God reminds him that no earthly power can stand against the one who rules over everything.

The psalm is not an invitation to vindictiveness. It places justice in God’s hands. Paul would later say, “Never avenge yourselves, but leave it to the wrath of God” (Romans 12:19).

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus was falsely accused and “entrusted himself to him who judges justly” (1 Peter 2:23). He is the Righteous One, and he will return to judge the living and the dead (Acts 17:31). On the cross he committed his spirit to the Father (Luke 23:46). The wicked fall into their own pits, but the cross shows that God can turn even the pit into salvation (Acts 2:23-24).

STEP 6

Application

If you have been falsely accused or treated unjustly, bring the case to God rather than defending yourself in anger.

Search your own heart honestly, as David did. Is there anything you need to confess?

Give thanks that God is a righteous judge.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to search your heart and show you where you have sinned.
- Leave in his hands a wrong done to you.
- Thank Jesus for trusting the Father with his cause.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 36

“Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart.”

1 SAMUEL 16:7

DAY 251 · WEEK 36

Psalm 11; Psalm 12

In the LORD I take refuge; save, O LORD

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 11 and Psalm 12. Both psalms respond to a world where the foundations seem to be crumbling. Notice what David says about the LORD in each.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 11 was written when David's friends were advising him to flee like a bird to the mountains. Psalm 12 laments the decline of honest speech in the community. Both are attributed to David and fit the period of Saul's persecution, when the order of the kingdom was breaking down. They are paired here because together they address the question of what to do when righteousness seems to be losing.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In the LORD I take refuge; how can you say to my soul, Flee like a bird to your mountain" (11:1).
2. "If the foundations are destroyed, what can the righteous do?" (11:3).
3. "The LORD is in his holy temple; the LORD's throne is in heaven; his eyes see, his eyelids test the children of man" (11:4).
4. "For the LORD is righteous; he loves righteous deeds; the upright shall behold his face" (11:7).
5. "Save, O LORD, for the godly one is gone; for the faithful have vanished from among the children of man" (12:1).
6. "Everyone utters lies to his neighbor; with flattering lips and a double heart they speak" (12:2).

7. “Because the poor are plundered, because the needy groan, I will now arise, says the LORD; I will place him in the safety for which he longs” (12:5).

8. “The words of the LORD are pure words, like silver refined in a furnace on the ground, purified seven times” (12:6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 11 begins with a tempting suggestion from friends: run. “The wicked bend the bow; they have fitted their arrow to the string to shoot in the dark at the upright in heart.” Things look dangerous, and the foundations of order are shaking. The question, “What can the righteous do?” is an honest one. David’s answer is not to deny the danger but to look past it: “The LORD is in his holy temple; the LORD’s throne is in heaven.” The foundations may shake, but the throne does not.

The point is that God sees. His eyes “test the children of man.” He is not absent, and he is not passive. He loves righteous deeds, and he will deal with the wicked. For those who trust him, the final promise is the best: “The upright shall behold his face.” To see God’s face is the greatest reward of the faithful.

Psalm 12 turns to a different danger: the corruption of speech. Lies, flattery, and the boasting of the proud have taken over. The godly seem to have vanished. Anyone who feels isolated in their commitment to truth will recognize the mood. David does not hide the situation, and he brings it to God.

God answers in the middle of the psalm, in his own voice. “Because the poor are plundered, because the needy groan, I will now arise.” He hears the groaning of the poor, and he acts. It is one of the most comforting words in the Psalter.

The contrast with human words is stark. The speech of men is double-hearted, but “the words of the LORD are pure words, like silver refined in a furnace.” When all speech around us is unreliable, the word of God is the one thing we can trust completely. He will keep us and guard us from this generation forever.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the truth (John 14:6), the Word who is himself pure and without deceit (1 Peter 2:22). Hebrews 12:27-28 speaks of receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken. He is in heaven now, at the right hand of the throne (Hebrews 8:1). Matthew 5:8 says, “Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God,” echoing Psalm 11:7. Revelation 22:4 says, “They will see his face.”

STEP 6

Application

When you feel the urge to flee, remember that the LORD is on his throne.

Examine your own speech this week. Where is there flattery or exaggeration in it?

Open your Bible with trust that these words are pure and reliable.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what feels shaken in your life right now.
- Ask him to keep your lips from flattery and your heart undivided.
- Thank him that his words are pure and trustworthy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 36

"Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart."

1 SAMUEL 16:7

DAY 252 · WEEK 36

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Samuel 16:7 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart."

1 SAMUEL 16:7

REST

Meditation

God says this to Samuel as he stands before Jesse's oldest son, tall and impressive. It is a correction to every human way of judging.

"Man looks on the outward appearance." We evaluate people by how they look, speak, and perform. We do it to others, and we do it to ourselves. Entire industries run on this habit, and so do many of our fears. We worry about how we appear.

"But the LORD looks on the heart." God sees what is hidden. He sees motives, desires, loves, and fears. This can be frightening, because nothing is concealed from him. But it is also freeing. If he sees the heart, then the person who is overlooked, the one who is left with the sheep, may be the one he has chosen. And the one who looks impressive may be empty.

David was not chosen for his strength or his looks. The next passage says he was handsome, but that was not why. God saw a heart that was oriented toward him. Even so, David's heart was not perfect, as the coming chapters will show. The verse does not say that David's heart

was without sin, only that it was what God was looking for.

For the Christian, there is both warning and comfort. Warning, because religious appearances do not impress him. Comfort, because he sees our sincere faith even when we feel weak, and because the righteousness we stand in is not our own but Christ's. Pray the words of Psalm 139: "Search me, O God, and know my heart."

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read of Saul's rejection and the choosing of David. You saw Jonathan's bold faith, and Saul's partial obedience in the war with Amalek, with Samuel's verdict that to obey is better than sacrifice. You read how God looked past Jesse's older sons to anoint the shepherd boy, and how David met Goliath in the name of the LORD of hosts. You saw Saul's jealousy grow, and the covenant friendship of David and Jonathan. In the Psalms you prayed with David in his weeping, and in a time of false accusation, and in a world where the foundations were shaking. The week taught that God judges by the heart, that the battle belongs to the LORD, and that he is a refuge for the oppressed.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

God looks at the heart and not at appearances. What part of your heart do you most need to bring into the light?

David was a shepherd who became a champion for his people. How does Jesus, the greater Shepherd and Champion, give you hope in a battle you cannot win?

Jonathan gave up his claim to the throne out of loyalty. Where is God asking you to put his purposes ahead of your own advancement?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to search your heart and lead you in the way everlasting.

Thank Jesus for fighting for you and winning.

Rest in his care today.

DAY 253 · WEEK 37

Psalm 13; Psalm 14

How long?, and: the LORD looks down from heaven

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 13 and Psalm 14. Psalm 13 is a short lament that ends in trust, and Psalm 14 describes the state of humanity without God. Read the two together.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Both psalms are attributed to David. Psalm 13 is the shortest of the great laments, with only six verses, and many readers have found that it expresses the experience of waiting on God better than any other. Psalm 14 is a sober assessment of human sin, which Paul quotes in Romans 3. They are paired in the Psalter, and here they sit during David's years on the run, when answers were slow to come.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "How long, O LORD? Will you forget me forever? How long will you hide your face from me?" (13:1).
2. "How long must I take counsel in my soul and have sorrow in my heart all the day?" (13:2).
3. "Light up my eyes, lest I sleep the sleep of death" (13:3).
4. "But I have trusted in your steadfast love; my heart shall rejoice in your salvation" (13:5).
5. "I will sing to the LORD, because he has dealt bountifully with me" (13:6).
6. "The fool says in his heart, There is no God" (14:1).
7. "The LORD looks down from heaven on the children of man, to see if there are any who understand, who seek after God" (14:2).

8 “They have all turned aside; together they have become corrupt; there is none who does good, not even one” (14:3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The structure of Psalm 13 is a model for lament. First comes the complaint, four times repeated: “How long?” David feels forgotten, hidden from, and abandoned in his own thoughts. Second comes the request: “Consider and answer me, O LORD my God.” Third comes the turn: “But I have trusted in your steadfast love.” The final line is a vow of praise.

The turn is the key. Nothing has changed in David’s situation. There is no explanation of how the enemy will be defeated. What changes is that David decides to trust. The word “trusted” is in the past tense, as though he were holding on to what he already knows. He recalls the covenant love of God and remembers that he has been dealt with bountifully before. Lament leads to trust not by getting answers, but by returning to what God has already revealed about himself.

Psalm 14 is darker. The fool, in the Bible, is not someone of low intelligence but a person who lives as though there were no God. The fool says it “in his heart,” meaning that it is a practical atheism more than a formal argument. The result is corruption. The psalm describes God looking down over the whole human race and finding no one who seeks him.

This is a hard truth, and it is the basis of the gospel. “There is none who does good, not even one.” Human beings cannot find their own way to God. Paul uses these lines in Romans 3 to prove that all, Jew and Gentile, are under sin.

Yet the psalm ends with hope: “Oh, that salvation for Israel would come out of Zion!” If humans cannot save themselves, then salvation must come from God. And the psalm says that God is “the refuge” of the poor and that he is with the generation of the righteous.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Psalm 14:1-3 in Romans 3:10-12 to show that all are under sin, and then shows that God’s righteousness comes by faith in Christ (Romans 3:21-26). Salvation did come out of Zion in Jesus (Romans 11:26). Jesus cried, “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” (Matthew 27:46) so that we might never be forsaken. Ephesians 2:4-5 says that God, being rich in mercy, made us alive.

STEP 6

Application

If you are in a long season of waiting, pray Psalm 13 aloud as your own.

Notice where you live as a practical atheist, making plans without God.

Thank God that salvation did come out of Zion.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God how long you have been waiting, and what for.

Confess where you have lived as though there were no God.

Thank him for sending salvation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 37

"The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold."

PSALM 18:2

DAY 254 · WEEK 37

1 Samuel 21:1-23:29

David flees; Ahimelech; David at Adullam

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 84 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 21:1-23:29. David is now a fugitive. Notice the mix of fear, faith, and God's guidance in these chapters, and read the horror of chapter 22 carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

David has escaped from Saul's court and has nothing: no weapons, no army, and no safe place. He flees first to Nob, where the priest Ahimelech helps him, and then to Gath, to the cave of Adullam, and elsewhere. A band of distressed men gathers around him. Saul's pursuit becomes more violent, and the priests of Nob pay a terrible price. Through it all, David inquires of the LORD and is guided.

STEP 3

Observation

1. David lies to Ahimelech and receives the bread of the Presence and Goliath's sword (21:1-9).
2. In Gath, David feigns madness before King Achish to escape (21:10-15).
3. At the cave of Adullam, "everyone who was in distress, and everyone who was in debt, and everyone who was bitter in soul, gathered to him" (22:2).
4. Doeg the Edomite reports David's visit to Nob, and at Saul's order he strikes down eighty-five priests (22:9-19).
5. Abiathar, one son of Ahimelech, escapes and joins David (22:20-23).
6. David asks the LORD, "Shall I go and attack these Philistines?" and the LORD says, "Go" (23:2).

7. Jonathan visits David and says, “You shall be king over Israel, and I shall be next to you” (23:16-17).

8. Saul almost captures David at the wilderness of Maon, but is called away by a Philistine raid (23:26-29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David’s flight shows that being chosen by God is not the same as being comfortable. He has been anointed king, and he is in a cave. The pattern is clear in many Bible stories: before glory comes hardship, and God uses the wilderness to shape his servants. David was formed as a king in the same years that he was hunted as an outlaw.

His behavior in these chapters is mixed. His lie to Ahimelech has terrible consequences, and David later admits his responsibility: “I have occasioned the death of all the persons of your father’s house” (22:22). Scripture does not hide the flaws of its heroes. David is not the model king because he never fails. He is the model because he repents, inquires of the LORD, and clings to God’s promises.

The band that gathers at Adullam is striking. The distressed, the indebted, and the bitter come to him. This is a company of misfits, and David becomes their captain. It is an image of what a faithful king does: he receives those who have nowhere else to go.

The massacre at Nob is one of the darkest scenes in the book. Saul’s own officers refuse to touch the priests, and the Edomite Doeg does it. A king who began with the Spirit of God is now killing the LORD’s priests. The anger that began as envy ends in sacrilege.

Against the darkness, the LORD guides David. Again and again, David inquires through the ephod, and God answers. In chapter 23, the people of Keilah would betray him, but God warns him, and he escapes. Jonathan comes to him “and strengthened his hand in God.” The chapter ends with a narrow escape, which the place name records as “the Rock of Escape.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus, the Son of David, was also rejected by his own, and in his ministry those in distress, in debt, and bitter of soul gathered to him (Luke 15:1; Matthew 11:28). Jesus cited David’s eating of the bread of the Presence to show that mercy outranks ritual (Matthew 12:3-4). Hebrews 11:38 says of the faithful that they “wandered about in deserts and mountains and in dens and caves of the earth.”

STEP 6

Application

If you are in a wilderness season, remember that God may be forming you.

Ask God for guidance in a decision, as David did, before you act.

Think about who the “distressed, indebted, and bitter” are around you, and how you might welcome them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God about a wilderness where you feel he is forming you.

Thank Jesus for welcoming those who have nowhere else to go.

Ask him to strengthen you in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 37

“The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold.”

PSALM 18:2

DAY 255 · WEEK 37

1 Samuel 24:1-26:25

David spares Saul twice; Abigail's wisdom

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 24:1-26:25. David has two chances to kill Saul, and he refuses both. Notice his reasoning each time, and how he deals with the foolish Nabal in chapter 25.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Saul pursues David with three thousand men. In a cave at En-gedi, Saul unknowingly enters the very cave where David and his men are hiding. In chapter 26, David finds Saul asleep in his camp. Between these two scenes comes the story of Nabal, a rich, foolish man who insults David, and Abigail, his wise wife, who prevents David from taking revenge. The three stories together form a lesson on restraint.

STEP 3

Observation

1. David's men say, "Here is the day of which the LORD said to you, Behold, I will give your enemy into your hand" (24:4).
2. David cuts off a corner of Saul's robe, and his heart strikes him (24:5).
3. "I will not put out my hand against my lord, for he is the LORD's anointed" (24:10).
4. Saul weeps and says, "You are more righteous than I, for you have repaid me good, whereas I have repaid you evil" (24:17).
5. Nabal's name means "fool," and he insults David's men and refuses them bread (25:3-11).
6. Abigail brings food and says, "Let this be no cause of grief to my lord… that you have avenged yourself with your own hand" (25:31).
7. David says, "Blessed be the LORD… who has sent you this day to meet me! Blessed be your discretion" (25:32-33).

8 In chapter 26, David again spares Saul, and says, “The LORD rewards every man for his righteousness and his faithfulness” (26:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

These three chapters ask what we do when we have the power to repay a wrong. David is not a weak man. He has a company of warriors. He is fleeing for his life. Saul has tried to kill him many times. When he has the chance, his men tell him that God has given his enemy into his hand. They might even say it with scriptural confidence. But David will not touch the LORD’s anointed.

His reason is not weakness. It is faith. If God has promised him the throne, God will give it in his own time. David does not need to seize it. To kill Saul would be to take for himself what God has promised to give. Instead of grasping, he waits. This is the opposite of Saul’s attitude in 1 Samuel 13.

Nabal provides a test of a different kind. David’s anger is provoked by an ordinary insult, and he sets out to wipe out Nabal’s household. Abigail, wise and quick, intervenes. She brings gifts and speaks gracefully, and she reminds David of his calling. “Let it not be a cause of grief or pangs of conscience to my lord that you have shed blood without cause.” David hears her, and he praises God. It is a healthy sign that the king can be corrected, even by a woman he has never met.

Not every enemy is a Saul. Some are just fools. And the response is different. David is stopped by Abigail’s wisdom, and later Nabal dies when the LORD strikes him.

The refrain of the section is that vengeance belongs to the LORD. “The LORD will judge between me and you,” David says to Saul. When David leaves vengeance to God, he is free from guilt. And the lesson is not passivity, but trust that God will do justice.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you” (Matthew 5:44), and on the cross he prayed, “Father, forgive them” (Luke 23:34). Paul says, “Repay no one evil for evil… leave it to the wrath of God” (Romans 12:17-19). Peter holds up Christ as the one who “when he was reviled, did not revile in return” (1 Peter 2:23). Abigail is a peacemaker, like those Jesus called blessed (Matthew 5:9).

STEP 6

Application

Name someone who has wronged you. Pray for them today, and entrust them to God.

Ask whether you are trying to take by your own hand something that God has promised to give.

Thank God for the people who have corrected you with wisdom.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give God the desire to repay a wrong done to you.

Ask him for David's restraint and Abigail's wisdom.

Thank Jesus for praying for his enemies.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 37

"The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold."

PSALM 18:2

DAY 256 · WEEK 37

Psalm 18:1-30

The LORD is my rock and my fortress

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 30 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 18:1-30. This is David's great song of deliverance. Today read the first half, with its images of rescue and its confession of who God is.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The title says David spoke this song "to the LORD on the day when the LORD rescued him from the hand of all his enemies, and from the hand of Saul." It is also found, with small changes, in 2 Samuel 22, which you will read soon. Psalm 18 looks back on all of David's flight and sums up what he learned. It stands here at the end of the years of fleeing, as David's own testimony.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I love you, O LORD, my strength" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold" (v. 2).
3. "The cords of death encompassed me; the torrents of destruction assailed me" (v. 4).
4. "In my distress I called upon the LORD; to my God I cried for help. From his temple he heard my voice" (v. 6).
5. "Then the earth reeled and rocked; the foundations also of the mountains trembled" (v. 7).
6. "He rode on a cherub and flew; he came swiftly on the wings of the wind" (v. 10).
7. "He sent from on high, he took me; he drew me out of many waters" (v. 16).

8 “He brought me out into a broad place; he rescued me, because he delighted in me” (v. 19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with love: “I love you, O LORD.” It is not an argument or a doctrine. It is an expression of the heart. And then David piles up images, seven of them in one verse: rock, fortress, deliverer, refuge, shield, horn of salvation, stronghold. He has been in caves and on cliffs, and he knows what a rock is. But he says that God is the true rock.

Then he describes the danger. The cords of death were around him. The torrents of destruction rushed at him. He was close to dying. And in that place, “I called upon the LORD.” This is the pattern of the whole Psalter: crying out, and being heard.

The description of God’s response is a spectacular poem. The earth shakes, smoke rises from his nostrils, he parts the heavens and comes down. The language is that of a storm and an earthquake, the imagery of the exodus and of Sinai. God comes to rescue one man in a cave. David is saying that the God of Sinai is the God who hears one frightened servant. His power is not remote but personal.

The rescue is described tenderly: “He drew me out of many waters.” The word for “drew” is the same as the one used for Moses (Exodus 2:10). “He brought me out into a broad place.” After years in narrow caves, David is brought to a spacious place. Why? “Because he delighted in me.” Behind the whole rescue is God’s delight in his servant. It is grace.

In verses 20 to 30, David speaks of his own righteousness. This must be read in context. He is not claiming sinlessness before God, but declaring that in the matter of his conflict with Saul, he has kept faith. And he rests on the principle that “with the merciful you show yourself merciful.” The final line of today’s reading is a famous one: “This God, his way is perfect; the word of the LORD proves true; he is a shield for all those who take refuge in him.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the ultimate rescued one. He was in the “cords of death,” and God raised him (Acts 2:24). Paul quotes verse 49 in Romans 15:9. Zechariah calls Christ “a horn of salvation” in Luke 1:69. Colossians 1:13 says that God “has delivered us from the domain of darkness.” And Psalm 18:2’s rock is Christ himself (1 Corinthians 10:4).

STEP 6

Application

Begin your prayer today with “I love you, O LORD.” Mean it.

Write down a time God brought you into a “broad place” after a narrow one.

Read verse 30 slowly: “His way is perfect.” Where do you struggle to believe it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you love him, and say why.

Thank him for drawing you out of many waters.

Ask him to teach you to take refuge in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 37

“The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold.”

PSALM 18:2

DAY 257 · WEEK 37

Psalm 18:31-50

He trains my hands for war

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 18:31-50. The second half of David's song moves from God's character to David's victories, and ends in praise among the nations.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first half of the psalm praised God as rescuer. The second half describes how God equips David for battle, gives him victory, and establishes his kingdom. It ends with a promise to praise God among the nations and a reference to "his anointed" and his offspring forever. This looks forward to the covenant you will read in 2 Samuel 7.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For who is God, but the LORD? And who is a rock, except our God?" (v. 31).
2. "The God who equipped me with strength and made my way blameless" (v. 32).
3. "He makes my feet like the feet of a deer and sets me secure on the heights" (v. 33).
4. "You have given me the shield of your salvation, and your right hand supported me, and your gentleness made me great" (v. 35).
5. "You made me the head of the nations; people whom I had not known served me" (v. 43).
6. "The LORD lives, and blessed be my rock, and exalted be the God of my salvation" (v. 46).
7. "For this I will praise you, O LORD, among the nations, and sing to your name" (v. 49).
8. "Great salvation he brings to his king, and shows steadfast love to his anointed, to David and his offspring forever" (v. 50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The second half of the psalm gives God credit for everything David has achieved. “The God who equipped me with strength.” “He trains my hands for war.” “You have given me the shield of your salvation.” David was a skilled warrior, but he does not say it. He says that God made him able. It is a model of how a believer should speak of any success.

One phrase stands out: “Your gentleness made me great.” The word is often translated “condescension” or “humility.” It is the picture of the great God bending down to raise a shepherd boy. David’s greatness is the result of God’s stooping. It is perhaps the most beautiful line in the psalm. God does not merely give power; he gives it with gentleness.

In verses 37 to 42, David describes his victories, in the strong language of ancient warfare. The point is not violence for its own sake, but the defeat of the enemies of God’s anointed. The nations that were hostile come to serve. David’s kingdom is established, and the psalm hints that it extends to people he had not known.

The ending is the most important part. David vows to praise God among the nations, a surprising foreshadowing of the mission of Israel to the world. And the last verse points beyond David: “Great salvation he brings to his king, and shows steadfast love to his anointed, to David and his offspring forever.” The promise is for David’s descendants. This is what God will say in the covenant of 2 Samuel 7.

The psalm is a model of how to remember. It begins with love and ends with a promise. Everything in between is thanksgiving for what God has done.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes verse 49 in Romans 15:9 to show that the Messiah praises God among the Gentiles. Jesus is “David’s offspring forever,” the anointed who brings great salvation (Luke 1:32-33). Matthew 11:29 says that Jesus is “gentle and lowly in heart.” Philippians 2:5-11 shows him humbling himself and being exalted. Hebrews 2:13 puts words of Psalm 18 on Christ’s lips.

STEP 6

Application

When you succeed at something, practice saying, “God equipped me.”

Think about a time when God’s gentleness, not force, brought you through.

Pray for the nations to come to praise him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for equipping and supporting you.

Thank him for his gentleness that makes you great.

Pray that his salvation would reach the nations.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 37

"The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold."

PSALM 18:2

DAY 258 · WEEK 37

Psalm 54; Psalm 59

O God, save me by your name; deliver me from my enemies

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 16 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 54 and Psalm 59. Both come from the years when David was hunted by Saul, and both are brief prayers of someone surrounded by enemies. Notice how each ends.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 54 has the title "when the Ziphites went and told Saul, Is not David hiding among us?" (see 1 Samuel 23:19). Psalm 59 was written "when Saul sent men to watch his house in order to kill him" (see 1 Samuel 19:11). They are two snapshots from the same terrifying period, in which David was betrayed by neighbors and cornered in his own home.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O God, save me by your name, and vindicate me by your might" (54:1).
2. "For strangers have risen against me; ruthless men seek my life; they do not set God before themselves" (54:3).
3. "Behold, God is my helper; the Lord is the upholder of my life" (54:4).
4. "With a freewill offering I will sacrifice to you; I will give thanks to your name, O LORD, for it is good" (54:6).
5. "Deliver me from my enemies, O my God; protect me from those who rise up against me" (59:1).
6. "They come back at evening, howling like dogs and prowling about the city" (59:6).
7. "O my Strength, I will watch for you, for you, O God, are my fortress" (59:9).
8. "But I will sing of your strength; I will sing aloud of your steadfast love in the morning. For you have been to me a fortress and a refuge in the day of my distress" (59:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 54 is among the shortest prayers in the Psalter, and it is a model of how to pray when under pressure. There are three movements. First, a cry for help. Second, a statement of trust: “Behold, God is my helper.” Third, a vow of thanksgiving. The “Behold” invites us to look. David is surrounded by enemies, but he asks us to look at the one who is on his side.

The Ziphites were from David’s own tribe of Judah. He was betrayed by his own people. This hurts. In the psalm, he describes them as “strangers,” and says they do not set God before them. The people we expect to defend us sometimes fail.

Psalm 59 comes from a house under siege. Saul’s men wait outside to kill David in the morning, and Michal helps him escape through a window. The psalm uses the image of dogs prowling at night, hungry, circling the city. It is a picture of terror. And yet the psalm repeatedly describes God as a fortress and a strength. David does not try to defeat the dogs. He turns to the one who is higher.

An important feature is the contrast between night and morning. The enemies prowl at evening. David sings in the morning. The long night of fear gives way to the dawn of praise. He says he will “watch” for God, like a watchman waiting for the sun.

What makes these psalms Christian prayers is the closing note. David promises to sing about the steadfast love of God, even before he has been rescued. This is faith that praises in advance. The believer does not wait for a perfect outcome before giving thanks.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus was betrayed by one of his own (John 13:18), and those who came to arrest him came at night with swords and clubs (Luke 22:52-53). Psalm 59:4-5 and 54:3 describe the hostility Jesus faced. Paul says, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” (Romans 8:31). Hebrews 13:6 quotes Psalm 118 but echoes the same confidence: “The Lord is my helper; I will not fear.”

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Psalm 54:4, “Behold, God is my helper.” Repeat it when you feel alone.

If you have been betrayed by someone close, bring it to God. He knows.

Practice morning praise: begin tomorrow by singing of his steadfast love.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God about those who surround or trouble you.
- Ask him to be your fortress and refuge.
- Sing of his strength and love in your own words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 37

"The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold."

PSALM 18:2

DAY 259 · WEEK 37

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 18:2 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold."

PSALM 18:2

REST

Meditation

This verse comes from a man who has lived in caves and on cliffs, and who knows what shelter is worth. David loads one sentence with seven images of God.

A rock is solid ground. When everything else is shifting, it holds. A fortress is a strong place that an enemy cannot enter. A deliverer pulls out of danger. A refuge is a place to hide, and a shield is a defense held up between you and an arrow. A horn of salvation is a symbol of strength and victory, like the horn of a wild ox. A stronghold is a high place that cannot be reached.

Each image answers a different fear. When you feel unstable, God is a rock. When you feel attacked, he is a fortress and a shield. When you are trapped, he is a deliverer. When you are exposed, he is a refuge. When you feel weak, he is a horn of salvation. When you feel

overwhelmed, he is a stronghold. David does not say that God gives these things. He says that God is these things.

Notice the repeated "my." David is not describing a general idea of divine power. He is speaking of the LORD as his own. It is personal faith.

Christians have always read this verse in the light of Christ. He is the rock (1 Corinthians 10:4), the cornerstone (1 Peter 2:6), the shield of faith's defender (Ephesians 6:16), and the horn of salvation raised up for us (Luke 1:69). Each time you read this verse, you may fill in the name of Jesus.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed David as a fugitive. You read how the priests at Nob were slaughtered, how the distressed and the indebted gathered to David at Adullam, and how God guided him through the wilderness. You saw David spare Saul twice, and you saw Abigail turn aside his anger against Nabal. In the Psalms, you heard David's love for the LORD in Psalm 18, his testimony of rescue and the God who equips with gentleness, and prayers in Psalms 54 and 59 from the hardest nights. The week taught that vengeance belongs to the LORD, that waiting is an act of faith, and that the God who delivers is both a rock and a gentle helper.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

David refused to seize the throne by force and waited on God's timing. What is God asking you to wait for rather than grab?

David praised God as rock, fortress, and deliverer. Which of those images do you most need this week, and how does Jesus fulfill it?

Abigail's wisdom turned David from a sin. Who has God used to correct you, and how might you thank them?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is your rock, fortress, and deliverer.

Thank him for the gentleness that makes you great.

Rest in his protection today.

DAY 260 · WEEK 38

Psalm 64; Psalm 70

Hide me from the wicked; make haste, O God, to deliver me

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 64 and Psalm 70. One is a prayer against slander and secret plots, and the other is a short cry for speedy help. Notice how each ends with confidence.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These two psalms are attributed to David and belong to the years of his persecution. Psalm 64 speaks of hidden enemies who sharpen their tongues like swords, and Psalm 70 is a five-verse petition, repeated almost word for word in Psalm 40:13-17. Both are brief, urgent, and honest.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Hear my voice, O God, in my complaint; preserve my life from dread of the enemy” (64:1).
2. “Who whet their tongues like swords, who aim bitter words like arrows” (64:3).
3. “They hold fast to their evil purpose; they talk of laying snares secretly, thinking, Who can see them?” (64:5).
4. “But God shoots his arrow at them; they are wounded suddenly” (64:7).
5. “Then all mankind fears; they tell what God has brought about and ponder what he has done” (64:9).
6. “Let the righteous one rejoice in the LORD and take refuge in him!” (64:10).
7. “Make haste, O God, to deliver me! O LORD, make haste to help me!” (70:1).
8. “But I am poor and needy; hasten to me, O God! You are my help and my deliverer; O LORD, do not delay!” (70:5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 64 is about the weapon of the tongue. David's enemies do not use swords. They use words, and they use them in secret. "They talk of laying snares secretly, thinking, Who can see them?" It is the voice of a conspiracy, of whispering and plotting. Slander is among the oldest weapons, and it is hard to defend against because it works in the dark.

David's answer is to bring the matter to God, who sees what is hidden. The whole psalm turns on the reversal of verse 7. The enemies shoot arrows from ambush, but God shoots an arrow at them. The ones who thought no one could see them are seen. "They are wounded suddenly." The tongues they used against others are turned back on themselves.

The result is awe. All mankind fears, and tells what God has done. The justice of God, when it falls, is a lesson to the world. And the righteous rejoice and take refuge. The psalm ends not with revenge, but with refuge.

Psalm 70 is shorter and more urgent. "Make haste" appears twice. David is in an emergency, and he does not pretend otherwise. His request is simple: help me, now. He describes himself as "poor and needy." It is the best position from which to pray. The person who knows they have nothing to offer can only receive.

Even in this hurried prayer, there is room for the praise of others: "May all who seek you rejoice and be glad in you! May those who love your salvation say evermore, God is great!" David cannot help thinking of others.

Together these prayers teach us two things. First, God sees what is done in secret. Second, we may pray urgently and simply, and we do not need elaborate words.

STEP 5

Connection

James 3:5-8 calls the tongue a fire and a restless evil, and Jesus warned that we will give an account for every careless word (Matthew 12:36). He was himself the target of plots made in secret (Mark 14:1). Psalm 64:3 is echoed in Revelation, and the "arrow" language has a New Testament counterpart in Romans 12:19. The poor and needy have a special place with Christ (Matthew 5:3; 2 Corinthians 8:9).

STEP 6

Application

If you have been the target of gossip, bring it to God. He sees what is hidden.

Examine your own tongue. Is there a whisper you should stop?

When you need help urgently, pray Psalm 70:5 as a short prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to protect you from slander and to keep your tongue from harming others.
- Tell him you are poor and needy.
- Ask him to hasten to help you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 38

"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God."

PSALM 20:7

DAY 261 · WEEK 38

1 Samuel 27:1-31:13

David among the Philistines; the witch of Endor; Saul's death

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 78 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 27:1-31:13. These chapters show David in Philistine territory, Saul's last night, and the end of Saul's reign. Read chapter 28 and chapter 31 with care.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Weary of running, David says in his heart, "I shall be swept away one day by the hand of Saul," and he takes refuge among the Philistines at Ziklag. Saul, meanwhile, faces the Philistine army at Gilboa with no word from God. He goes to a medium at Endor. The book ends with Saul's defeat and death on Mount Gilboa. It is a sober ending to the story of Israel's first king.

STEP 3

Observation

1. David lives among the Philistines for a year and four months and raids the Geshurites and Amalekites (27:1-12).
2. Saul, afraid, inquires of the LORD, "but the LORD did not answer him, either by dreams, or by Urim, or by prophets" (28:6).
3. Saul disguises himself and visits the medium at Endor, though he himself had expelled mediums (28:3, 7-8).
4. The spirit says, "Tomorrow you and your sons shall be with me" (28:19).
5. David returns to Ziklag to find it burned and the families taken, and "David strengthened himself in the LORD his God" (30:6).
6. David pursues and recovers everything, and divides the spoil fairly (30:7-25).

7. The Philistines defeat Israel at Gilboa; Jonathan and his brothers are killed, and Saul falls on his sword (31:1-6).
8. The men of Jabesh-gilead remember Saul's rescue of their city, and recover his body (31:11-13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David's choice to live among the Philistines is a low point for him. He is tired, and his faith slips. "David said in his heart, Now I shall perish." He does not ask the LORD. The man who has inquired of God so faithfully now decides on his own. He lies to the king of Gath and raids Israel's enemies while pretending to raid Judah. It is a messy period, and the narrative does not hide it. Even a man after God's own heart can have seasons of fear.

Saul's last night is among the saddest in the Bible. God is silent. And Saul, who had banished mediums, seeks out a medium. When the spirit appears, it announces the end of his kingdom and his life. Saul falls to the ground in terror and has no strength left. He had refused to obey God when he was able, and now God does not answer. It is a picture of the cost of persistent rebellion.

Chapter 30 is the counterweight. David returns to find Ziklag burned and his wives and children captured. His own men talk of stoning him. This is his lowest moment. And here is the most important sentence: "David strengthened himself in the LORD his God." He turns to God. He asks through the ephod, and God says, "Pursue, for you shall surely overtake and shall surely rescue." And so it happens.

The contrast with Saul is deliberate. Saul, in distress, consults a medium. David, in distress, strengthens himself in the LORD. Their endings differ accordingly.

Chapter 31 closes the story of Saul with a death that is tragic rather than triumphant. He dies in battle with his sons. Yet the men of Jabesh-gilead show loyalty and honor him. The book ends not with David's triumph but with a funeral. The way to the throne is open, but it is paved with grief.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus was tempted to take shortcuts but trusted the Father (Matthew 4). Hebrews 3:12-13 warns against hardening our hearts in unbelief. When Jesus was alone in the garden he found his strength in prayer (Luke 22:43-44). Paul says, "Be strong in the Lord and in the strength of his might" (Ephesians 6:10), and, "I can do all things through him who strengthens me" (Philippians 4:13).

STEP 6

Application

When you are discouraged, practice “strengthening yourself in the LORD.” What does that look like for you?

Think about where you turn first when you are afraid. Is it God, or something else?

Pray for someone who has hardened their heart to listen again.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what makes you afraid, and ask him to strengthen you.

Ask him to keep you from seeking answers in the dark.

Thank Jesus, who turned to the Father and never failed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 38

“Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God.”

PSALM 20:7

DAY 262 · WEEK 38

2 Samuel 1:1-3:39

David mourns Saul; anointed over Judah; Ish-bosheth

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 1:1-3:39. David grieves for Saul and Jonathan, and becomes king, first over Judah and then over a divided kingdom. Read his lament in chapter 1 carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second book of Samuel opens with a messenger bringing news of Saul's death. David's response is grief, not triumph. After the lament, God directs David to Hebron, where he is anointed king over Judah. For seven and a half years, there is civil war between David's house and the house of Saul. Abner, Saul's commander, eventually switches sides, and is murdered by Joab.

STEP 3

Observation

1. A man claims to have killed Saul and brings his crown to David. David has him executed because he "stretched out your hand to destroy the LORD's anointed" (1:14-16).
2. David's lament: "How the mighty have fallen!" (1:19, 25, 27).
3. "Saul and Jonathan, beloved and lovely! In life and in death they were not divided" (1:23).
4. "I am distressed for you, my brother Jonathan; very pleasant have you been to me; your love to me was extraordinary, surpassing the love of women" (1:26).
5. David inquires of the LORD, goes up to Hebron, and is anointed king over Judah (2:1-4).
6. "There was a long war between the house of Saul and the house of David. And David grew stronger and stronger" (3:1).

7. Abner makes a covenant with David, and Joab kills Abner in revenge for his brother (3:12-27).

8. David mourns Abner and says, “Do you not know that a prince and a great man has fallen this day in Israel?” (3:31-38).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David’s first act as the next king is to weep. The man who brings Saul’s crown expects a reward, but David has him killed. David has consistently honored Saul as the LORD’s anointed, and he will not profit from his death, even by a messenger’s lie. There is no gloating in his heart.

The lament in chapter 1 is a work of poetry and of real love. David praises Saul, who had pursued him for years, and Jonathan, his friend. He does not mention Saul’s failures. He mourns a king who fell, and he honors the good. The refrain “How the mighty have fallen!” echoes through the poem like a bell. It teaches that grief for the fallen is compatible with God’s judgment, and that we should be slow to speak ill of the dead.

When David is anointed in Hebron, he is told to go there by the LORD. He inquires. He has learned the lesson of dependence. But notice that he does not rush to take the whole kingdom. The war between the houses lasts seven years. He waits, and “David grew stronger and stronger, while the house of Saul grew weaker and weaker.”

The story of Abner and Joab shows the dangers of power. Abner brings the northern tribes over to David, a great peace. But Joab, for personal revenge, murders Abner. It is a stain on David’s reign. David declares his innocence, curses Joab’s house, and mourns publicly. He composes another lament for Abner. The people are pleased, “for all the people took note of it.” Yet David admits, “I am this day weak, though anointed king” (3:39). He is aware of the limits of his power.

The chapters teach that God’s promise is fulfilled slowly. David is king, but he must still grieve, wait, and deal with violence in his own camp.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus wept over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41) and at the tomb of Lazarus (John 11:35). He too was anointed king and had to wait for his kingdom. Hebrews 2:8-9 says, “At present, we do not yet see everything in subjection to him. But we see him… crowned with glory and honor.” Paul says, “Rejoice with those who rejoice, weep with those who weep” (Romans 12:15).

STEP 6

Application

Think of someone who has hurt you and has since died or fallen. Can you honor what was good in them?

Wait on God for what he has promised. Do not force the timing.

Grieve honestly over the losses in your life, and bring them to him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to teach you to grieve well and honor the fallen.

Ask him to make you patient as you wait for his promises.

Thank Jesus, the King who wept and will reign.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 38

"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God."

PSALM 20:7

DAY 263 · WEEK 38

Psalm 20

May the LORD answer you in the day of trouble

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 20. It is a prayer for the king before he goes into battle. Read it as a congregation praying for its leader.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 20 is a royal psalm "of David," in which the people pray for the king as he goes out to war. The speakers shift between "we" and "I," as the congregation prays and the king, or a priest, answers. David is now king, and the psalms of his kingship begin. After the long years of flight, the nation has a king whose success depends on God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD answer you in the day of trouble! The name of the God of Jacob protect you!" (v. 1).
2. "May he send you help from the sanctuary and give you support from Zion" (v. 2).
3. "May he remember all your offerings and regard with favor your burnt sacrifices" (v. 3).
4. "May he grant you your heart's desire and fulfill all your plans!" (v. 4).
5. "May we shout for joy over your salvation, and in the name of our God set up our banners!" (v. 5).
6. "Now I know that the LORD saves his anointed; he will answer him from his holy heaven" (v. 6).
7. "Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God" (v. 7).
8. "O LORD, save the king! May he answer us when we call" (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This psalm shows how a community prays for its leader. The people do not simply hope that the king will win. They ask the LORD to answer him, protect him, support him, and fulfill his plans. It is a model of intercessory prayer. A nation is stronger when its people pray for those who lead.

The psalm assumes that the king is a servant of God. His offerings are remembered. His plans are the plans God grants. Success is not the king's alone. The people shout for joy over "your salvation," but they raise their banners in "the name of our God." The glory goes to God.

The turning point is verse 6. A voice declares, "Now I know that the LORD saves his anointed." It is a statement of settled confidence. The prayer has been answered in the heart of the one who prays. This is common in the Psalms: prayer ends with certainty before the outcome is seen.

Verse 7 is the center of the psalm, and one of the most quoted lines in the Psalter. "Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God." Chariots and horses were the superweapons of the ancient world. Israel was told never to multiply horses (Deuteronomy 17:16). The psalm declares that real security is found in God's name, not in military power. In our time the chariots and horses may be money, technology, connections, or intelligence.

The closing line is a prayer that has become a national anthem for Israel: "O LORD, save the king!" In time, Israel's kings would fail, and this prayer would point to the King who does not.

STEP 5

Connection

The "anointed" of this psalm is the Messiah. Jesus was the king who went to battle against sin and death, and the Father heard him (Hebrews 5:7). "In the day of trouble" echoes his Gethsemane prayer. 1 Timothy 2:1-2 calls us to pray for kings and all in authority. Paul says that we trust "not in ourselves but in God who raises the dead" (2 Corinthians 1:9).

STEP 6

Application

Pray this psalm for a leader you know: a pastor, a boss, a government official.

Name your "chariots and horses," the things you trust in apart from God.

Pray "O LORD, save the king" with Jesus in mind, who reigns now.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you trust in when trouble comes, and what you want to trust instead.

Ask him to answer those who lead you in the day of trouble.

Raise your banner in his name by telling him why you trust him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 38

"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God."

PSALM 20:7

DAY 264 · WEEK 38

Psalm 21

The king rejoices in your strength

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 21. It is the companion to Psalm 20. There the people prayed for the king before battle, and here they give thanks for his victory.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 21 is a royal psalm of thanksgiving, likely used at a celebration of the king's accession or a victory. Psalms 20 and 21 should be read together, as a prayer followed by a praise. The king is a figure of joy in God's strength, and the psalm points beyond David to a king whose reign has no end.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, in your strength the king rejoices, and in your salvation how greatly he exults!" (v. 1).
2. "You have given him his heart's desire and have not withheld the request of his lips" (v. 2).
3. "For you meet him with rich blessings; you set a crown of fine gold upon his head" (v. 3).
4. "He asked life of you; you gave it to him, length of days forever and ever" (v. 4).
5. "His glory is great through your salvation; splendor and majesty you bestow on him" (v. 5).
6. "For you make him most blessed forever; you make him glad with the joy of your presence" (v. 6).
7. "For the king trusts in the LORD, and through the steadfast love of the Most High he shall not be moved" (v. 7).

8 “Be exalted, O LORD, in your strength! We will sing and praise your power” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Where Psalm 20 asked, Psalm 21 gives thanks. The pattern is a reminder that prayer is not only petition. Many of us ask and forget to thank. The people here return to God to say that he has answered. The king’s heart’s desire has been given. The language is of overflowing generosity: rich blessings, a crown of gold, glory, splendor, majesty.

A phrase in verse 4 is striking: “He asked life of you; you gave it to him, length of days forever and ever.” In terms of the historical David, “forever” might be read as a long life, or as the length of his dynasty. But “forever and ever” reaches further. It points to a king who will live and reign eternally. Psalm 21 asks us to read it with more than David in mind.

The root of the king’s blessing is stated at the end: “For the king trusts in the LORD.” His strength is not his own. The word “trusts” is the key to his success. He will not be moved, “through the steadfast love of the Most High.” The king’s security rests on God’s covenant love.

Verses 8 to 12 describe judgment on the king’s enemies. The imagery is strong: a fiery furnace, a consuming fire. These lines are not an invitation to violence, but a recognition that the reign of the LORD’s anointed brings the end of all who oppose him. It is a theme that runs from Psalm 2 to Revelation.

The psalm closes with a collective song. The people return their gaze from the king to the LORD: “Be exalted, O LORD, in your strength!” The king is blessed, but the center is always God.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 5:7-9 speaks of Christ who asked for deliverance from death and was heard. “Length of days forever and ever” is fulfilled in his resurrection (Acts 2:24-28; Revelation 1:18). “The joy of your presence” echoes Acts 2:28 and Hebrews 12:2. The crown of gold points to Revelation 14:14, where the Son of Man wears a golden crown. Philippians 2:9-11 says God has highly exalted him.

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of ways God has answered prayer in the last month, and thank him for each.

Ask what it means to rejoice in his strength rather than your own.

Give thanks for the King who lives forever.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for answered prayer and good gifts.
- Thank Jesus, who asked for life and was given it forever.
- Ask him to be exalted in his strength in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 38

"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God."

PSALM 20:7

DAY 265 · WEEK 38

2 Samuel 4:1-6:23

David king over all Israel; Jerusalem captured; the ark

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 74 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 4:1-6:23. David is made king over all Israel, takes Jerusalem, and brings the ark to the city. Notice the contrast between the two attempts to move the ark.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After Abner's death, Ish-bosheth, Saul's son, is murdered by two of his own captains, and the northern tribes come to David at Hebron. He is anointed king over all Israel. He then captures the Jebusite city of Jerusalem and makes it his capital. The ark of the covenant, which had been in obscurity since 1 Samuel 7, is brought to the city, but not without tragedy.

STEP 3

Observation

1. David has Ish-bosheth's murderers executed, saying, "How much more, when wicked men have killed a righteous man in his own house" (4:11).
2. All the tribes come to Hebron and say, "You shall be shepherd of my people Israel, and you shall be prince over Israel" (5:2-3).
3. David takes the stronghold of Zion, "that is, the city of David" (5:7).
4. "And David became greater and greater, for the LORD, the God of hosts, was with him" (5:10).
5. David defeats the Philistines twice, inquiring of the LORD each time (5:17-25).
6. The ark is carried on a new cart, and Uzzah reaches out to steady it and dies (6:1-8).
7. David fears the LORD that day and leaves the ark with Obed-edom, whom God blesses (6:9-11).

8. David dances “before the LORD with all his might” and Michal despises him in her heart (6:14-16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David’s rise to the throne over all Israel is the fulfillment of what God promised through Samuel. It is not the result of his own plotting. He has waited. When the tribes come to him, they acknowledge what God had said: “You shall be shepherd of my people Israel.” The term “shepherd” is a reminder of where David came from and what a king is for.

The capture of Jerusalem makes the city “the city of David.” It will become the center of Israel’s worship and, ultimately, of the story of salvation. The narrator says plainly why David succeeded: “The LORD, the God of hosts, was with him.” His greatness is a gift.

The story of the ark in chapter 6 is a lesson on how to approach a holy God. The first attempt copies the Philistines’ method, with a new cart. The ark was to be carried by the Levites on poles. When the cart is shaken, Uzzah reaches out and is struck down. It seems harsh, and David is angry and afraid. But the lesson is that God’s holiness is not to be handled casually, even with good intentions. Good motives do not override God’s instructions.

The second attempt, three months later, is done correctly, with sacrifices and with joy. David dances before the LORD, wearing a linen ephod. He is not too proud to be undignified before God. Michal looks down on him from a window. Her scorn is the scorn of those who prefer propriety to passion. David’s answer is that he will be “even more contemptible than this” for the LORD’s sake.

The chapters show a king who inquires of God, who is awed by his holiness, and who rejoices in his presence. This is the heart of true worship: reverence and joy together.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the true presence of God in the midst of his people (John 1:14). He rode into Jerusalem while the crowds rejoiced (Matthew 21:8-9), and some wanted the disciples to be silenced (Luke 19:39-40). Hebrews 12:28 says, “Let us offer to God acceptable worship, with reverence and awe.” Acts 5 shows a similar fear of God’s holiness in the early church.

STEP 6

Application

Ask if your worship is a mix of reverence and joy, or leans heavily in one direction.

Look at where you are doing a good thing in a way God did not instruct.

Think about whether you are afraid of looking foolish in worship, and ask God to free you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to teach you to worship with both reverence and joy.
- Confess where you have handled his word lightly.
- Thank him that in Jesus he is with you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 38

"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God."

PSALM 20:7

DAY 266 · WEEK 38

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 20:7 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God."

PSALM 20:7

REST

Meditation

This verse sets two kinds of trust side by side. It is a simple contrast, but it asks a searching question: where does your confidence rest?

Chariots and horses were the strongest military technology of the ancient Near East. An army with them was thought to be unbeatable. Israel was told not to depend on them (Deuteronomy 17:16; Isaiah 31:1). The psalm does not say that chariots are useless. It says that the people of God have a different foundation.

What are our chariots and horses? They are whatever we lean on for security instead of God. For some it is a bank account. For others, it is a résumé, a network of influential friends, good health, a clever plan, or a disciplined routine. These things are not evil. They are gifts. But when we trust in them, they become idols, and they fail.

“We trust in the name of the LORD our God.” In the Bible, a name stands for the whole person. To trust in God’s name is to trust in who he is: faithful, powerful, merciful, covenant-keeping. And notice the “we.” This is a community statement. We say it together, as a church.

The contrast in the next verse is vivid: “They collapse and fall, but we rise and stand upright.” Those who trust in horses fall. Those who trust in God stand.

For the Christian, the name of the LORD has been revealed in Jesus. “There is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved” (Acts 4:12). Hold this verse when you are tempted to feel safe because of something other than him.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed the end of Saul and the rise of David. You read Saul’s last night, when God was silent and he turned to a medium, and David’s response in his own low moment: he strengthened himself in the LORD his God. You read David’s lament over Saul and Jonathan, and how he became king first over Judah and then over all Israel. You saw him take Jerusalem and bring the ark to the city, after the sobering lesson of Uzzah. In the Psalms, you prayed for the king in Psalm 20 and gave thanks for him in Psalm 21. The week taught that God’s anointed trusts in the name of the LORD, that God’s holiness must be honored, and that true worship joins reverence with joy.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

David strengthened himself in the LORD when everything was taken from him. What does that look like for you in a hard season?

Psalm 21 says the king trusts in the LORD and will not be moved. How does Jesus, the King who trusted perfectly, give you security when you feel shaken?

What are the “chariots and horses” you are most tempted to trust? What would it look like to trust in the name of the LORD instead?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you trust in his name and not in chariots.

Thank him for the King who trusts him perfectly.

Rest in his strength today.

DAY 267 · WEEK 39

2 Samuel 7:1-29

The Davidic Covenant, the throne, the son, the kingdom forever

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 29 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 7:1-29. This is the pivotal chapter of the books of Samuel and one of the most important in the whole Bible. Read it slowly, twice if you can. It is the anchor of this unit.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

David is settled in his palace in Jerusalem, and the LORD has given him rest from his enemies. He feels it is wrong that he lives in a house of cedar while the ark dwells in a tent. He tells the prophet Nathan that he wants to build a house for God. God responds, through Nathan, with a promise that turns David's plan inside out. This is the Davidic covenant.

STEP 3

Observation

1. David says, "See now, I dwell in a house of cedar, but the ark of God dwells in a tent" (7:2).
2. The LORD says, "Would you build me a house to dwell in?... I took you from the pasture, from following the sheep, that you should be prince over my people Israel" (7:5-8).
3. "I will make for you a great name, like the name of the great ones of the earth" (7:9).
4. "The LORD declares to you that the LORD will make you a house" (7:11).
5. "I will raise up your offspring after you... and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever" (7:12-13).
6. "I will be to him a father, and he shall be to me a son. When he commits iniquity, I will discipline him with the rod of men" (7:14).
7. "But my steadfast love will not depart from him" (7:15).

8 “And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever” (7:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David’s desire is good. He wants to honor God. But God’s reply reverses the direction. David wants to build a house for God, and God says that he will build a house for David. The word “house” is used in two senses: a building and a dynasty. God will give David a lasting line of kings. The initiative belongs to God, and the covenant is one of pure promise. David has done nothing to earn it. He was a shepherd, and God made him a king.

The promises are staggering. A great name. A place for Israel, secure from enemies. A son who will build the temple. And above all, a throne established forever. Verse 13 says that God will establish the throne of the kingdom “forever,” and verse 16 repeats it. This is a promise that no human king can fulfill by himself, for every king dies. Even Solomon, the immediate son, will fall. The promise points to a royal line that does not end, and ultimately to a king who lives forever.

Verse 14 is also important. The king is called God’s son: “I will be to him a father, and he shall be to me a son.” This echoes Psalm 2. It is a statement about the closeness between God and the Davidic king. If the king sins, he will be disciplined, but the covenant will not be cancelled. This differs from Saul. God’s steadfast love is the basis. The promise is unconditional in its ultimate outcome and personal in its fatherly discipline.

David’s prayer in response is one of the most beautiful in Scripture. He goes in and sits before the LORD, and says, “Who am I, O Lord GOD, and what is my house, that you have brought me thus far?” He is overwhelmed. He praises God’s greatness and his choosing of Israel. And he ends with a humble request: “Do as you have promised.” He rests on the word of God.

In the larger story, this chapter is the pivot. All the earlier covenants, with Abraham, with Israel at Sinai, narrow now to a king from David’s line. All the later prophecy points to this son of David. The Bible becomes the story of the search for the promised King.

STEP 5

Connection

The New Testament opens with “the book of the genealogy of Jesus Christ, the son of David” (Matthew 1:1). Gabriel tells Mary that “the Lord God will give to him the throne of his father David, and he will reign over the house of Jacob forever” (Luke 1:32-33). Peter says that David “being a prophet… foretold the resurrection of the Christ” (Acts 2:30-31). Hebrews 1:5 quotes 2 Samuel 7:14 of Jesus. Revelation 22:16: “I am the root and the descendant of David.”

STEP 6

Application

Read David's prayer in verses 18 to 29 aloud as your own prayer of thanksgiving.

Ask where you are trying to do something for God when he is asking you to receive something from him.

Thank God that the throne of David is held forever by Jesus.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what it means that he has brought you this far.

Thank him for the promise to David and its fulfillment in Jesus.

Ask him to establish what he has begun in you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 39

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 268 · WEEK 39

Psalm 22:1-21

My God, my God, why have you forsaken me, the suffering king

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 22:1-21. This is the psalm Jesus quoted from the cross. Read it in its own setting first, as David's cry. Then read it again with Good Friday in mind.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 22 is a psalm of David, titled "According to The Doe of the Dawn." We do not know the event that prompted it, and it uses language that goes beyond anything recorded in David's life. It begins in the deepest abandonment and ends in universal praise. Placed after the covenant of 2 Samuel 7, it shows that the promised King will suffer before he reigns. Today's reading covers the first twenty-one verses, the lament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? Why are you so far from saving me?" (v. 1).
2. "O my God, I cry by day, but you do not answer, and by night, but I find no rest" (v. 2).
3. "But I am a worm and not a man, scorned by mankind and despised by the people" (v. 6).
4. "All who see me mock me; they make mouths at me; they wag their heads" (v. 7).
5. "He trusts in the LORD; let him deliver him; let him rescue him, for he delights in him!" (v. 8).
6. "I am poured out like water, and all my bones are out of joint; my heart is like wax" (v. 14).

7. “For dogs encompass me; a company of evildoers encircles me; they have pierced my hands and feet” (v. 16).

8. “They divide my garments among them, and for my clothing they cast lots” (v. 18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Read as David’s own cry, this psalm describes the experience of feeling abandoned by God while surrounded by enemies. The opening words are shocking. “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” David does not say, “Why have you stopped helping?” He says, “You have forsaken me.” The Bible permits us to pray the language of felt abandonment. It does not hide it.

But even in the question, there is faith. He still says “My God.” The psalm contains a long review of what God has done in the past: “In you our fathers trusted; they trusted, and you delivered them.” David cannot square the past with the present. This tension is the heart of a lament. He does not resolve it with a quick answer. He keeps praying.

The imagery is graphic. “A worm and not a man.” Mockers wag their heads. “I am poured out like water.” Bones out of joint. A tongue stuck to the jaws. A pack of dogs. Hands and feet pierced. Garments divided by lot. David describes his suffering in terms that go far beyond what history records of him. These details were fulfilled in the death of Jesus, almost word for word.

At the end of the section the tone shifts. Verses 19 to 21 are a cry for help: “But you, O LORD, do not be far off! O you my help, come quickly to my aid!” He finishes with “You have rescued me from the horns of the wild oxen.” Even in the pit, he knows who to call.

This psalm shows us that the suffering of the righteous is not a sign of God’s absence. It is part of the pattern of how God’s anointed enters into glory. It prepares us for the cross.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus cried the first line of this psalm from the cross (Matthew 27:46; Mark 15:34). The mockery of verses 7 and 8 is repeated by the passersby and chief priests (Matthew 27:39-43). The dividing of garments is quoted in John 19:24. The thirst of verse 15 is in John 19:28. The piercing of hands and feet is seen in the crucifixion itself. Jesus entered the darkness of abandonment so that we would never be truly forsaken (2 Corinthians 5:21; Hebrews 13:5).

STEP 6

Application

If you are in a season of feeling far from God, pray this psalm. Do not hide.

Read the crucifixion account in John 19 alongside this psalm, and notice the details.

Thank Jesus that he was forsaken so you would not be.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for being forsaken so that you would not be.

Tell God where you feel far from him.

Praise him that he is near and has not hidden his face.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 39

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 269 · WEEK 39

Psalm 24

Lift up your heads, O gates, the King of glory enters

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 24. Read it as a processional song, with questions and answers. Picture the ark being carried up to the city, and the gates opening to receive the King.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

You read Psalm 24 earlier, in Unit 6, as part of the story of the temple and God's presence. Here it appears again, in its natural setting after the ark's arrival in Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6). It is likely the very song sung when David brought the ark up to Zion. Today, read it with that scene in mind, and notice how it moves from the whole earth to a single hill, and from the hill to the King who enters.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The earth is the LORD's and the fullness thereof, the world and those who dwell therein" (v. 1).
2. "For he has founded it upon the seas and established it upon the rivers" (v. 2).
3. "Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place?" (v. 3).
4. "He who has clean hands and a pure heart, who does not lift up his soul to what is false" (v. 4).
5. "He will receive blessing from the LORD and righteousness from the God of his salvation" (v. 5).
6. "Lift up your heads, O gates! And be lifted up, O ancient doors, that the King of glory may come in!" (v. 7).

7. “Who is this King of glory? The LORD, strong and mighty, the LORD, mighty in battle!” (v. 8).

8. “Who is this King of glory? The LORD of hosts, he is the King of glory!” (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm has three movements, and the second reading adds a layer to each. First, a declaration: the whole earth belongs to the LORD. He made it and holds it together. The God who has come to Zion is not a local deity. He is the Creator of all. When David brought the ark to Jerusalem, he was bringing the throne of the God of the whole earth.

Second, a question: “Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD?” Having just read of Uzzah, the question is sharp. Not everyone can approach God in any way they like. The answer is a person of clean hands and a pure heart, whose actions and desires are right. But no one fits that description perfectly. The question hangs over the reader, and it prepares for the good news that someone has fulfilled it.

Third, a procession. The company reaches the gates of the city and calls on them to open. The call-and-response is dramatic: “Who is this King of glory?” The answer comes: “The LORD, strong and mighty.” Then the call is made again, and the answer is expanded: “The LORD of hosts.” The king who comes is the commander of the heavenly armies.

Having read the account of the ark’s arrival, we see how the psalm fits. The ark, a symbol of God’s throne, is brought into the city. But no gate in Jerusalem could finally contain him. The psalm points beyond the ark to the day when the King of glory would truly enter the city.

The key move is from the heights to the humble. The one who owns the whole earth comes to a particular hill. The one who is infinitely holy invites sinners to come near, if they are clean. The gospel is that he makes us clean.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the one with clean hands and a pure heart, the only one who can ascend the hill of the LORD. He entered Jerusalem as King (Matthew 21:9), and he ascended into heaven, where the gates are lifted for him (Hebrews 4:14; Ephesians 4:8-10). We ascend with him by faith, clothed in his righteousness (2 Corinthians 5:21; Hebrews 10:19-22). Paul quotes verse 1 in 1 Corinthians 10:26.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God that your access to him does not depend on your clean hands, but on Christ’s.

Look at how you treat what you have. If the earth is the LORD's, so are your possessions.

Open the gates of your heart to the King of glory today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Open a gate in your life for the King of glory, and name it.
- Thank Jesus, who ascended with clean hands and clothes you in his righteousness.
- Praise God that the earth and everything in it is his.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 39

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 270 · WEEK 39

2 Samuel 8:1-10:19

David's victories; Mephibosheth, covenant kindness

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 8:1-10:19. David's kingdom reaches its height, and he shows kindness to Mephibosheth. Notice what David does with the covenant love he has received.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the covenant of chapter 7, the narrative shows the LORD giving David victory on every side. Chapter 8 summarizes his conquests and his administration. Chapter 9 turns from war to mercy, as David seeks out any survivor of Saul's house to show kindness for Jonathan's sake. Chapter 10 returns to war with the Ammonites and Arameans. This is the high point of David's reign.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And the LORD gave victory to David wherever he went" (8:6, 14).
2. "So David reigned over all Israel. And David administered justice and equity to all his people" (8:15).
3. David asks, "Is there still anyone left of the house of Saul, that I may show him the kindness of God?" (9:3).
4. Mephibosheth, Jonathan's son, is crippled in both feet and living in Lo-debar (9:3-5).
5. "Do not fear, for I will show you kindness for the sake of your father Jonathan, and I will restore to you all the land of Saul your father, and you shall eat at my table always" (9:7).
6. Mephibosheth bows and says, "What is your servant, that you should show regard for a dead dog such as I am?" (9:8).

7. “So Mephibosheth lived in Jerusalem, for he ate always at the king’s table. Now he was lame in both his feet” (9:13).

8. Joab says, “Be of good courage, and let us be courageous for the sake of our people, and for the cities of our God, and may the LORD do what seems good to him” (10:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 8 is a record of success, and it is framed by the repeated phrase, “The LORD gave victory to David wherever he went.” David’s reign is blessed because God is with him. He also dedicates the plunder to the LORD (8:11). The chapter closes with a summary of his administration, and with the key statement that he “administered justice and equity to all his people.” A king’s greatness is measured by his justice.

Chapter 9 is the gem of the section. It is a story of grace. Saul’s family was David’s enemy. Under the customs of the time, a new king would eliminate the old dynasty’s heirs. Instead, David asks, “Is there anyone left that I may show the kindness of God?” The phrase “kindness of God” means covenant faithfulness (the Hebrew word is the one translated “steadfast love”). He is acting out of a promise he made to Jonathan (1 Samuel 20:14-17).

Mephibosheth is a picture of every sinner. He was lame in both feet, hiding in a place called Lo-debar (“no pasture”), thinking of himself as a dead dog. He expected death. Instead, he is called, brought to the king’s table, given land, and treated as one of the king’s sons. “You shall eat at my table always.” He did nothing to earn it. He was invited because of what the king promised to another.

The scene ends with a line that is easy to miss: “Now he was lame in both his feet.” His condition did not change. He was seated at the king’s table with his disability intact. Grace does not require us to be healed before we are welcomed.

Chapter 10 returns to war and shows the other side of the king. But David is no longer the man who fears. He trusts the LORD for the result.

STEP 5

Connection

The story of Mephibosheth is a picture of the gospel. We were far from the King, crippled by sin, and expecting judgment. But for the sake of the Son, we are brought near and seated at the table (Ephesians 2:13; Luke 22:29-30). Jesus invited the lame and the poor to his banquet (Luke 14:13-23). Revelation 19:9 speaks of the marriage supper of the Lamb. Titus 3:4-5 speaks of the kindness of God our Savior.

STEP 6

Application

Think of yourself as Mephibosheth. Let the picture of being brought to the table sink in.

Ask who in your life needs “the kindness of God” from you, someone who expects nothing.

Remember that you do not have to be fixed before you come to Jesus.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for his kindness to you, shown for the sake of his Son.
- Ask him to teach you to show that kindness to someone who cannot repay it.
- Thank him for a seat at his table.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 39

“And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever.”

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 271 · WEEK 39

2 Samuel 11:1-12:31

David and Bathsheba; Nathan's rebuke

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 55 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 11:1-12:31. This is the darkest chapter of David's life. Read it slowly and honestly. Notice how sin grows, how Nathan confronts it, and what God says in response to David's repentance.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is spring, when kings go out to war, but David stays in Jerusalem. From his roof he sees a woman bathing. What follows is adultery, deception, and murder. After months of silence, the prophet Nathan is sent to confront him. The chapters record the cost of David's sin and the shape of true repentance.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In the spring of the year, the time when kings go out to battle, David sent Joab... But David remained at Jerusalem" (11:1).
2. David sees Bathsheba, sends for her, and sleeps with her. She becomes pregnant (11:2-5).
3. David tries to cover it up by recalling Uriah from battle, and when that fails, has Joab put Uriah in the front line to be killed (11:6-25).
4. "But the thing that David had done displeased the LORD" (11:27).
5. Nathan tells a parable about a rich man who takes a poor man's only lamb, and says, "You are the man!" (12:1-7).
6. "I anointed you king over Israel... Why have you despised the word of the LORD, to do what is evil in his sight?" (12:7-9).

7. David says, “I have sinned against the LORD.” Nathan replies, “The LORD has put away your sin; you shall not die” (12:13).

8. “Nevertheless… the child who is born to you shall die” (12:14). David worships, and later Solomon is born, “and the LORD loved him” (12:15-25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sin begins with an idle moment. David was not where he should have been. He sees, wants, takes. He moves from lust to adultery, to the abuse of power, to deception, to murder. At each step he tries to cover the previous sin with a worse one. It is a picture of how sin multiplies. The narrator does not excuse him. The king who should have been guarding justice becomes its violator. The phrase “But David remained at Jerusalem” is where the story starts to unravel.

For a year, he seems to have gotten away with it. But “the thing that David had done displeased the LORD.” God sends Nathan, who tells a story. David’s anger is aroused against the rich man in the parable, and he pronounces judgment. Then Nathan says, “You are the man.” It is the moment of truth. The king who judged others is judged himself.

God’s words through Nathan are heartbreaking. He recounts what he has given David and says, “If this were too little, I would add to you as much more.” David despised God’s word and did evil. It is an act of ingratitude as well as of lust.

David’s response is brief and real. “I have sinned against the LORD.” There is no excuse, no blaming. And Nathan answers with some of the most precious words in the Old Testament: “The LORD has put away your sin; you shall not die.” Forgiveness is immediate and complete. But consequences remain. The child dies, and the sword will not depart from David’s house. Grace does not cancel the effects of sin in this world.

The scene shows both the severity and the mercy of God. He does not ignore sin, even in his favorite. And he does not refuse forgiveness to the one who confesses. At the end, God gives the couple a son, Solomon, whom he loves.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says, “Where sin increased, grace abounded all the more” (Romans 5:20). Paul quotes Psalm 32, which David wrote after this episode, in Romans 4:6-8 as a description of justification by faith. Matthew’s genealogy mentions “Uriah’s wife” (Matthew 1:6), reminding us that Jesus came through this broken line. Christ is the greater David who, unlike David, never abused his power, and who laid down his life instead of taking another’s.

STEP 6

Application

Look for places where you are “staying home” when you should be at your post. What is the first step you could take away from temptation?

If you are hiding something, bring it to God now. Do not wait for a Nathan.

Remember that forgiveness is real and complete, even when consequences remain.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess honestly where you have sinned, and do not cover it.
- Ask him to keep you from the “roof” where temptation finds you.
- Thank Jesus for bearing the sin you confess.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 39

“And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever.”

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 272 · WEEK 39

Psalm 32

Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 32. David wrote this after the events of the last reading. It is a song of forgiveness, and one of the great teaching psalms in the Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The title calls it "A Maskil of David," meaning a song of instruction. It seems to reflect on the period after his sin with Bathsheba, the silence of the months when he hid it, and the relief that came when he confessed. It is one of the seven traditional penitential psalms, but it is characterized more by joy than by sorrow. Placed right after Day 271, it tells the other side of the story.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered" (v. 1).
2. "Blessed is the man against whom the LORD counts no iniquity, and in whose spirit there is no deceit" (v. 2).
3. "For when I kept silent, my bones wasted away through my groaning all day long" (v. 3).
4. "For day and night your hand was heavy upon me; my strength was dried up as by the heat of summer" (v. 4).
5. "I acknowledged my sin to you, and I did not cover my iniquity; I said, I will confess my transgressions to the LORD, and you forgave the iniquity of my sin" (v. 5).
6. "You are a hiding place for me; you preserve me from trouble; you surround me with shouts of deliverance" (v. 7).

7. “I will instruct you and teach you in the way you should go; I will counsel you with my eye upon you” (v. 8).

8. “Many are the sorrows of the wicked, but steadfast love surrounds the one who trusts in the LORD” (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a double blessing, and uses three words for sin: transgression, sin, and iniquity. Each is matched with a word for forgiveness: forgiven, covered, and not counted. The piling up of terms shows how thoroughly God deals with every type of wrong. He lifts it away, covers it, and does not count it against us.

David then describes the misery of hiding his sin. His body suffered. His bones wasted away. God’s hand was heavy on him. The groaning went on all day. The guilt of unconfessed sin is not just a spiritual problem. It touches the whole person. David knew by experience that silence and concealment do not work. They drain strength like summer heat.

Then comes the turn, in verse 5: “I acknowledged my sin to you.” Notice the three verbs: acknowledged, did not cover, confessed. And the result: “You forgave.” The speed of it is striking. David says he will confess, and God forgives. This is the same forgiveness Nathan announced. God is not reluctant. He is eager to forgive.

The rest of the psalm shows what follows from forgiveness. God becomes a hiding place. The man who ran from God now runs to him. God also becomes a teacher: “I will instruct you.” The forgiven person is ready to learn. And God’s counsel is personal, “with my eye upon you.” The forgiven are guided, not like a mule that needs a bit and bridle, but like a person who follows willingly.

The final verses are an invitation to the whole community: “Be glad in the LORD, and rejoice, O righteous, and shout for joy, all you upright in heart!” Forgiveness leads to joy.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul uses verses 1 and 2 in Romans 4:6-8 as proof that God justifies the ungodly by faith, and not by works. “Blessed is the man against whom the Lord will not count his sin.” This is the heart of justification: the imputing of righteousness and the non-imputing of sin. Christ became sin for us, so that we might become the righteousness of God (2 Corinthians 5:21). 1 John 1:9 says, “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us.”

STEP 6

Application

If there is any sin you are hiding, confess it today. Do not wait.

Read verses 1 and 2 as a description of your status in Christ.

Ask God to counsel you with his eye upon you. Then listen.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Acknowledge your sin to God without covering it.
- Thank him for the forgiveness that makes you blessed.
- Ask him to be your hiding place.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 39

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 273 · WEEK 39

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Samuel 7:16 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. This is the anchor verse for the whole unit. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

REST

Meditation

This verse is the center of the unit. It is God's promise to David, spoken through Nathan, and it is one of the most important sentences in the Old Testament.

"Your house." David wanted to build God a house, and God promises to build his. This is a dynasty, a line of descendants who will sit on the throne. Every promise in the Bible after this moment hangs on this one thread: a son of David.

"And your kingdom." It is not just a family that is promised, but a realm. The kingdom of David is the kingdom of God's rule on earth, carried out through a human king.

"Shall be made sure forever before me." The word "sure" means firm and established. The promise rests on God's own faithfulness. David's later sin would not cancel it. His descendants' failures would not cancel it. God said it, and it stands.

“Your throne shall be established forever.” The repetition of “forever” is key. Every king in the line of David died. Solomon, in all his glory, fell into idolatry. The kingdom was divided, and the last king of Judah was taken to Babylon in chains. Yet the promise was never withdrawn. The prophets kept saying that a son of David would come, who would reign forever. Isaiah called him “the Prince of Peace.”

For the Christian, this verse is fulfilled in Jesus. “He will be great and will be called the Son of the Most High. And the Lord God will give to him the throne of his father David, and he will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of his kingdom there will be no end” (Luke 1:32-33). When you say this verse, you are saying that Jesus reigns. Memorize it. It is a promise that cannot fail.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week brought David to the throne and to the center of God’s plan. You read the end of Saul at Gilboa and the lament of David over Saul and Jonathan. You saw David anointed over all Israel, take Jerusalem, and bring the ark up with dancing. You read the heart of the unit, the covenant of 2 Samuel 7, in which God promised David a house, a kingdom, and a throne forever. You saw David’s grace to Mephibosheth, and then the dark chapters of his sin with Bathsheba and his repentance. In the Psalms you prayed for the king in Psalm 20, gave thanks in Psalm 21, and heard the cry of Psalm 22, which Jesus prayed on the cross. Psalm 24 welcomed the King of glory, and Psalm 32 celebrated forgiveness. The week taught that God keeps his promises to David in spite of David’s sin, and that the true King would suffer and reign.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

God took David from the pasture and made him king, without any merit on David’s part. What has God done for you that you did not earn?

The covenant promised a son of David whose throne would last forever. How does Jesus fulfill this promise, and what does his reign mean for your life this week?

David hid his sin until Nathan confronted him, and then he confessed and was forgiven. Is there something you have been hiding? What would it look like to bring it into the light?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the promise to David and for Jesus, whose throne lasts forever.

Thank him for forgiveness that covers every sin.

Ask him to make you tender to his word.

DAY 274 · WEEK 40

Psalm 51

Create in me a clean heart, David's penitential psalm

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 19 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 51. You read this psalm earlier in Unit 6. Today read it in its original setting, as David's prayer right after Nathan confronted him. Read it slowly, as his own words.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The title says, "A Psalm of David, when Nathan the prophet went to him, after he had gone in to Bathsheba." You met this psalm in Unit 6 as a general prayer of repentance. Having now read 2 Samuel 11 and 12, you can hear it as a particular man's prayer after a particular fall. Notice how little he says about the circumstances, and how much he says about God and his own heart.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Have mercy on me, O God, according to your steadfast love; according to your abundant mercy blot out my transgressions" (v. 1).
2. "Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin!" (v. 2).
3. "Against you, you only, have I sinned and done what is evil in your sight" (v. 4).
4. "Behold, I was brought forth in iniquity, and in sin did my mother conceive me" (v. 5).
5. "Purge me with hyssop, and I shall be clean; wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow" (v. 7).
6. "Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me" (v. 10).
7. "Cast me not away from your presence, and take not your Holy Spirit from me" (v. 11).
8. "The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit; a broken and contrite heart, O God, you will not despise" (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David begins with God's character, not his own record. "According to your steadfast love... according to your abundant mercy." He has no defense and no excuse, so he asks for mercy. Three words for sin appear again, as in Psalm 32: transgression, iniquity, and sin. And three requests: blot out, wash, cleanse. He knows the problem is deep.

Verse 4 is surprising. "Against you, you only, have I sinned." David had sinned against Bathsheba and Uriah and the nation. Yet he says that the offense is against God. This does not deny the harm to others, but recognizes that every sin is first of all a rebellion against the Creator, whose law has been broken. When we see sin at that level, we understand why it requires forgiveness, not just repair.

Verse 5 is not an excuse but a confession of depth. David realizes that his sin did not come out of nowhere. It flows from a nature that has been bent since birth. The problem is not only what he did, but what he is. He needs more than a new start. He needs a new heart, and so he prays, "Create in me a clean heart." The verb "create" is the one used in Genesis 1. Only God can make a new heart from nothing.

He also asks, "Take not your Holy Spirit from me." He had seen what happened to Saul. His fear is of losing God's presence, not of losing the throne. Then he asks for the joy of salvation and for a willing spirit.

The psalm ends with the great principle: "The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit." God does not need religious performance as a substitute for repentance. A broken and contrite heart he will not despise. He receives the one who comes with nothing.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the answer to David's prayer. By his blood we are washed (1 John 1:7; Revelation 1:5), and in him we are a new creation (2 Corinthians 5:17). Ezekiel 36:26 promises a new heart and the gift of the Spirit, fulfilled in the new covenant. Jesus said, "Blessed are the poor in spirit" (Matthew 5:3), and told the story of the tax collector who cried, "God, be merciful to me, a sinner!" (Luke 18:13).

STEP 6

Application

Use this psalm as a pattern for confession. Pray through it slowly, line by line.

Ask for more than forgiveness. Ask for a clean heart and a right spirit.

Thank God that he does not despise a broken and contrite heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pray Psalm 51 in your own words, naming what needs cleansing.
- Ask him to create a clean heart and a right spirit in you.
- Ask him not to take his Spirit from you, and thank him for Jesus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 40

"Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."

PSALM 51:10

DAY 275 · WEEK 40

2 Samuel 13:1-14:33

Amnon and Tamar; Absalom's revenge

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 13:1-14:33. These chapters show the first consequences of David's sin: violence and division within his own house. Read them with sorrow. They are painful.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Nathan told David that "the sword shall never depart from your house" (12:10). Chapters 13 and 14 show that word beginning to come true. David's son Amnon rapes his half-sister Tamar. Her brother Absalom murders Amnon, and flees. After three years, Joab arranges for Absalom's return. The family that David has built is breaking apart.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Amnon desires Tamar, and on the advice of Jonadab, pretends to be ill and asks that Tamar bring him food (13:1-9).
2. Tamar says, "No, my brother, do not violate me, for such a thing is not done in Israel" (13:12).
3. Amnon rapes her and then hates her "with very great hatred" and throws her out (13:14-17).
4. "When King David heard of all these things, he was very angry" (13:21). He does nothing.
5. Absalom says nothing to Amnon, "either good or bad," for he hated him (13:22).
6. After two years, Absalom has Amnon killed at a sheep-shearing feast, and flees to Geshur (13:23-38).

7. A wise woman of Tekoa, sent by Joab, tells David a story about two sons, so that he will bring Absalom back (14:1-20).

8. Absalom returns, but David will not see him for two years, and when they finally meet, "the king kissed Absalom" (14:28-33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

These chapters are among the saddest in the Bible. The violence in David's house echoes his own sin. A son takes what he wants from a woman. A father fails to act. Another son murders in revenge. The pattern of David's sins, desire, deception, and bloodshed, is repeated by his children. Children often imitate what their parents have done, and they usually take it further.

Tamar is the innocent victim. Her words to Amnon are wise and clear, and she even tells him to ask the king to give her to him in marriage. He will not hear. After the assault, she tears her robe and puts ashes on her head and lives "a desolate woman" in Absalom's house. The Bible does not minimize her pain. Her story reminds readers that the effects of abuse are real, and that God sees. Her cry, "Where could I carry my shame?" is heard.

David's failure is the lack of action. "He was very angry," says the text, but he does nothing. The Greek and Dead Sea texts add that he did not rebuke Amnon "because he was his firstborn and he loved him." David's own guilt may have left him unable to discipline his sons. A leader who has lost moral authority through unrepented sin cannot easily correct others.

Absalom's two years of silence is a picture of bitterness that is growing. Then the murder. His flight and the ensuing exile set the stage for the rebellion in chapters 15 to 18. David's half-hearted attempt to deal with the matter, bringing Absalom home but keeping him from his presence, solves nothing. Reconciliation without truth does not heal.

The tragedy is that David's confession and God's forgiveness did not remove the consequences. Forgiveness restores our relationship with God. It does not undo what we have set in motion. This is why sin is so serious, and why the cross is so necessary.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the opposite of David as a father and king. He defends the vulnerable and rebukes oppressors (Matthew 23:14; Mark 9:42). He is the one who "binds up the brokenhearted" (Isaiah 61:1; Luke 4:18). Hebrews 12:15 warns against a "root of bitterness" that causes

trouble. Ephesians 4:26-27 warns against letting anger give the devil a foothold. Galatians 6:7 says, “Whatever one sows, that will he also reap.”

STEP 6

Application

If you are a parent or leader, ask where you have failed to act when you should have.

Pray for those who have suffered abuse. Ask God to help you listen and believe.

Examine any bitterness you are nursing, and bring it to God before it grows.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pray for those who have been wronged, and for comfort for the desolate.
- Ask him to keep you from nursing bitterness.
- Ask him to give leaders courage to act justly.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 40

“Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me.”

PSALM 51:10

DAY 276 · WEEK 40

2 Samuel 15:1-17:29

Absalom's rebellion; David flees Jerusalem

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 15:1-17:29. Absalom leads a rebellion, and David flees Jerusalem. Notice how David responds, and how God works behind the scenes through Hushai and Ahithophel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Absalom has spent years winning the hearts of the people at the city gate. At last he declares himself king at Hebron, and David, hearing that "the hearts of the men of Israel have gone after Absalom," flees Jerusalem on foot. This is the setting for Psalm 3. These chapters are a long account of betrayal, loyalty, and the hidden hand of God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Absalom stole the hearts of the men of Israel" (15:6).
2. David leaves the city, weeping, barefoot, with his head covered, and says, "If I find favor in the eyes of the LORD, he will bring me back" (15:25-30).
3. Ittai the Gittite swears loyalty: "As the LORD lives, and as my lord the king lives, wherever my lord the king shall be, whether for death or for life, there also will your servant be" (15:21).
4. David prays, "O LORD, please turn the counsel of Ahithophel into foolishness" (15:31).
5. Hushai pretends loyalty to Absalom, to counter Ahithophel's advice (15:32-37; 17:5-14).
6. Shimei curses David, and David says, "Let him alone, and let him curse, for the LORD has told him to" (16:5-14).

7. “For the LORD had ordained to defeat the good counsel of Ahithophel, so that the LORD might bring harm upon Absalom” (17:14).
8. Ahithophel sets his house in order and hangs himself (17:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Absalom’s rebellion is the working out of Nathan’s prophecy. His method is subtle. He wins people by flattery, by promising justice, and by acting like a friend of the common man. It is a pattern of political manipulation as old as humanity: a man who “steals hearts” by appearing to offer what the king does not. He is charming, handsome, and ruthless.

David’s response is remarkable for its humility. He could fight. But he leaves the city, weeping, barefoot. He does not cling to the throne. Even the ark, which Zadok brings out, he sends back: “If I find favor in the eyes of the LORD, he will bring me back… But if he says, I have no pleasure in you, behold, here I am, let him do to me what seems good to him.” David has learned that he cannot manipulate God. He accepts whatever God decides.

His humility is tested by Shimei, who throws stones and curses him. David’s men want to kill Shimei. David says to leave him. Perhaps God has told him to curse. This is not weakness but a grasp that God may be using even insult to discipline him.

The contest between Ahithophel and Hushai shows God’s hidden providence. Ahithophel’s counsel was said to be like the word of God. David prays that it will be turned into foolishness. Hushai gives Absalom worse advice, and Absalom accepts it. The narrator tells us plainly: “The LORD had ordained to defeat the good counsel of Ahithophel.” God was at work behind the scenes, though no miracle was seen. Ahithophel, seeing that his advice was rejected, hangs himself.

The lesson is that God’s purposes are not defeated by human betrayal. He works through ordinary decisions, conversations, and even through bad advice.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus, too, left the city, crossed the Kidron, and went up the Mount of Olives weeping, and he was betrayed by one of his own counselors (2 Samuel 15:23, 30; John 18:1; Luke 22:47-48; Luke 19:41). Judas, like Ahithophel, hanged himself (Matthew 27:5). Jesus declared that the Father’s will would be done. And Romans 8:28 says that God works all things together for good.

STEP 6

Application

Practice David's humility: in a conflict, ask, "What if God is using this to teach me?"

Think about a time when God's hidden hand turned something for good, and thank him.

Pray, as David did, for wisdom and for confusion of plans that oppose his purposes.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you David's humility when you are wronged.
- Thank Jesus for being betrayed by his own for you.
- Trust him with what is happening behind the scenes.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 40

"Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."

PSALM 51:10

DAY 277 · WEEK 40

Psalm 63

O God, you are my God; earnestly I seek you

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 63. David prays in the wilderness of Judah. Read it as a song of longing and satisfaction. Notice how much it says about desire for God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The title reads, “A Psalm of David, when he was in the wilderness of Judah.” This may refer to the days when he fled from Saul, or when he fled from Absalom and crossed the wilderness near the Jordan (2 Samuel 15:23; 16:2, 14). Today it fits well with the last reading. A king in exile, with nothing, finds that he still has what matters most.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “O God, you are my God; earnestly I seek you; my soul thirsts for you; my flesh faints for you, as in a dry and weary land where there is no water” (v. 1).
2. “So I have looked upon you in the sanctuary, beholding your power and glory” (v. 2).
3. “Because your steadfast love is better than life, my lips will praise you” (v. 3).
4. “So I will bless you as long as I live; in your name I will lift up my hands” (v. 4).
5. “My soul will be satisfied as with fat and rich food, and my mouth will praise you with joyful lips” (v. 5).
6. “When I remember you upon my bed, and meditate on you in the watches of the night” (v. 6).
7. “For you have been my help, and in the shadow of your wings I sing for joy” (v. 7).
8. “My soul clings to you; your right hand upholds me” (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The setting is a desert, and the images are thirst and hunger. David has lost his palace, his bed, and his table. Yet in the wilderness he finds that what he truly wants is God himself. “My soul thirsts for you; my flesh faints for you.” It is the language of deep desire. This is not a lukewarm interest in religion. It is the longing of someone who knows he cannot live without God.

He remembers the sanctuary. He has seen God’s glory there. The memory of worship sustains him in a place where there is no sanctuary. Past experiences of God, stored in the heart, can carry us through dry seasons. This is why corporate worship and memory matter.

The central statement is verse 3: “Your steadfast love is better than life.” This is an extraordinary claim. David loves life. Yet he declares that God’s love is better. It is the confession of a man who has been stripped of everything except God and has found it to be enough. In the Bible, the greatest good is not life, comfort, or safety, but God’s steadfast love.

The satisfaction he describes in verse 5 is the answer to the thirst in verse 1. In the desert he is feasting. The paradox is that those who thirst for God are satisfied by him. He meditates on God in the night, lifting his hands in the darkness. He senses the shelter of God’s wings, a picture of a parent bird.

Verse 8 balances the whole psalm: “My soul clings to you; your right hand upholds me.” There is a double movement. David clings, and God holds. Faith is a grasping, and also a being held. Both are true.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they shall be satisfied” (Matthew 5:6), and “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink” (John 7:37). Philippians 3:8 shows Paul counting everything as loss for the sake of knowing Christ. Jesus also went into the wilderness and drew near to the Father (Luke 5:16). Revelation 7:16-17 promises that the redeemed will no more hunger or thirst.

STEP 6

Application

Ask if your desire for God is a thirst, or only a habit. Ask him to increase it.

In the next dry or lonely time, recall a moment when you knew God’s presence.

Say aloud, “Your steadfast love is better than life.” Where do you struggle to believe it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what your soul thirsts for.
- Tell him that his love is better than life, and why.
- Ask him to uphold you as you cling to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 40

"Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."

PSALM 51:10

DAY 278 · WEEK 40

Psalm 61

Hear my cry, O God; lead me to the rock

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 61. It is a short prayer from the ends of the earth. Notice the images of rock, tent, and wings.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 61 is attributed to David and is traditionally linked to his exile east of the Jordan, during Absalom's rebellion, when he felt "from the end of the earth." It follows Psalm 63 in this reading as a second prayer from the wilderness. It is only eight verses, but it reaches from the farthest place to the king's throne.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hear my cry, O God, listen to my prayer" (v. 1).
2. "From the end of the earth I call to you when my heart is faint" (v. 2).
3. "Lead me to the rock that is higher than I" (v. 2).
4. "For you have been my refuge, a strong tower against the enemy" (v. 3).
5. "Let me dwell in your tent forever! Let me take refuge under the shelter of your wings!" (v. 4).
6. "For you, O God, have heard my vows; you have given me the heritage of those who fear your name" (v. 5).
7. "Prolong the life of the king; may his years endure to all generations!" (v. 6).
8. "May he be enthroned forever before God; appoint steadfast love and faithfulness to watch over him!" (v. 7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with an honest statement of distance and weakness. David is far from home, and his heart is faint. The phrase “the end of the earth” conveys that he is as far from help as he can imagine. Yet he calls. Prayer does not depend on proximity. We can pray from anywhere, to a God who hears.

His request is vivid: “Lead me to the rock that is higher than I.” The prayer recognizes that he cannot reach safety on his own. The rock is higher than he is. He needs to be led. It is an admission of dependence. We cannot climb to safety by our own strength, and God must bring us there.

The language of refuge builds: a rock, a strong tower, a tent, the shelter of wings. David has seen all kinds of shelters, and he knows what he needs. In the middle of the psalm, he declares a desire to “dwell in your tent forever.” It is a longing for permanent communion, not just a rescue.

Then, surprisingly, he prays for the king. “Prolong the life of the king.” David is speaking of himself in the third person, or speaking of the king as an office. In either case, his prayer extends beyond his own survival to the continuance of the royal line. He asks that steadfast love and faithfulness would “watch over him.” It connects with 2 Samuel 7, the covenant that David has received.

The psalm ends in vow-keeping: “So will I ever sing praises to your name, as I perform my vows day after day.” Prayer and praise are daily acts.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus, the true king whose years “endure to all generations,” is the Rock that is higher than we are (1 Corinthians 10:4). He is the tent where God dwells with man (John 1:14; Revelation 21:3), and he spoke of gathering Jerusalem “as a hen gathers her brood under her wings” (Matthew 23:37). Hebrews 7:25 says that he “always lives to make intercession” for those who draw near to God through him.

STEP 6

Application

When you feel far away, pray this prayer: “From the end of the earth I call to you.”

Pick a metaphor from verses 2 to 4 (rock, tower, tent, wings) and spend time with it.

Pray for the leaders of your church and nation, as David prayed for the king.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry to God from wherever you are today.
- Ask him to lead you to the rock higher than you.
- Thank him for the King who reigns forever.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 40

"Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."

PSALM 51:10

DAY 279 · WEEK 40

2 Samuel 18:1-19:43

Absalom defeated; David restored, grief and kingship

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 18:1-19:43. Absalom is defeated and killed, and David mourns. Notice David's grief and Joab's rebuke, and how David is restored to Jerusalem.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

David's forces, led by Joab, Abishai, and Ittai, meet Absalom's army in the forest of Ephraim. David has told his commanders to deal gently with Absalom. The battle goes to David, but Absalom is caught by his hair in a tree and killed by Joab. David's grief is so great that it threatens the victory. Slowly, he is brought back across the Jordan and restored.

STEP 3

Observation

1. David commands, "Deal gently for my sake with the young man Absalom" (18:5).
2. Absalom's mule runs under an oak, and his head catches in the branches. Joab thrusts three javelins into his heart (18:9-15).
3. A Cushite brings the news, and David asks, "Is it well with the young man Absalom?" (18:29-32).
4. "O my son Absalom, my son, my son Absalom! Would I had died instead of you, O Absalom, my son, my son!" (18:33).
5. "So the victory that day was turned into mourning for all the people" (19:2).
6. Joab says, "You have today covered with shame the faces of all your servants… because you love those who hate you and hate those who love you" (19:5-6).
7. David sits in the gate, and the people come before him (19:8).

8. The tribes of Israel argue over who has the greater claim to bring the king back. David shows mercy to Shimei, and Mephibosheth appears with a loyal heart (19:9-40).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The battle itself is told briefly. What matters is its aftermath. A father has lost a son who tried to kill him, and he weeps. David's love for Absalom is deep and painful. It is also a love marked by failure. He had not corrected Absalom, he had not reconciled with him properly, and now he has no chance to do so. His cry, "Would I had died instead of you," is among the most poignant words in the Old Testament. It shows a father's heart, and it is also impossible. A man cannot die in place of another. But another Son would.

Joab's rebuke is harsh, but not without truth. The people are being demoralized by the king's grief. A leader must carry both his own sorrow and his responsibility. David listens, rises, and sits in the gate. He lets his duty override his mourning for the moment. Grief is real, but it does not excuse neglect.

Chapter 19 shows David's ability to forgive. He pardons Shimei, who had cursed him. He is gracious to Mephibosheth, who had been slandered by his servant Ziba. He tries to repair division between the tribes. David is not perfect, and there are signs of favoritism and quarrel, but the broad picture is of a king who restores rather than avenges.

The Jordan crossing is symbolic. David returns to the land, to the city, and to the throne, passing through the water, as Israel did under Joshua. After the exile of Absalom's rebellion, David is restored. It is a small picture of the great restoration that the prophets would later promise: God's king returning to Zion.

The lasting image is of the grieving father. The story of Absalom is the story of a son who would not be reconciled, and a father who would have given anything to save him.

STEP 5

Connection

The cry "Would I had died instead of you" finds its answer in Christ, who did die in our place (Romans 5:8). God the Father gave up his own Son for rebels (Romans 8:32). Unlike David's grief, the cross is not an unproductive tragedy but a victory. Jesus, like David, wept over his enemies (Luke 19:41). And as David showed mercy to Shimei, Jesus said, "Father, forgive them" (Luke 23:34).

STEP 6

Application

Think about a relationship where reconciliation was delayed. Is there something you could say today?

If you are grieving, be honest about it. And also ask how grief and duty can live together.

Show mercy to someone who has cursed you, as David did to Shimei.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for giving his Son for rebels like you.

Pray for those who grieve and for divided families.

Ask him to teach you to love those who have wronged you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 40

"Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."

PSALM 51:10

DAY 280 · WEEK 40

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 51:10 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."

PSALM 51:10

REST

Meditation

This is a prayer for those who have discovered that their problem is deeper than their behavior. David asks God not simply to forgive what he has done but to change who he is.

"Create." The Hebrew verb is bara, used in Genesis 1:1 for God's making of the heavens and earth. Only God creates. David is saying that he cannot produce a clean heart on his own. No amount of effort, resolution, or discipline will do it. It must be a gift, a work of God's creative power.

"A clean heart." In the Bible, the heart is the center of the person: thoughts, desires, will, and affections. A clean heart is a heart purified of whatever defiles. David knows that the root of his sin was not an isolated action but the condition of his heart.

"Renew a right spirit." The word "renew" implies that something steadfast once existed and has been lost. He asks for a spirit that is firm and fixed in the right direction, one that will not waver.

"Within me." The work must be inward. Religion that changes only the surface is not enough. This is what the prophets promised in the new covenant: "I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you" (Ezekiel 36:26).

For the Christian, this prayer is answered at conversion and continues through sanctification. We are born again (John 3:3-6), and the Spirit is at work making us new. Yet we keep praying this prayer, because we are still being made clean. Pray it daily.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week took David from the heights to the depths. You read the early Psalm 51 in its setting, David's prayer after Nathan's confrontation. You saw the family consequences of his sin: the assault on Tamar, Absalom's murder of Amnon, and Absalom's rebellion. You followed David out of Jerusalem, weeping, with his head covered, and saw how God worked behind the scenes through Hushai. You read the psalms of the wilderness, with Psalm 63's thirst and Psalm 61's cry from the end of the earth. You saw Absalom die and David grieve, and his gracious restoration. The week taught that forgiveness does not erase consequences, that God works through human frailty, and that the human heart needs to be re-created by God.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

David prayed for a clean heart because he saw that his problem went deeper than behavior. What do you see about your heart that behavior changes alone cannot fix?

David wished he could have died in place of his son, but could not. How does Jesus, who did die in our place, answer the grief behind that cry?

Psalm 63 says God's steadfast love is better than life. In what areas of life do you find it hardest to believe that?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to create in you a clean heart.

Thank him for the Son who died in your place.

Rest in him, asking him to satisfy your soul.

DAY 281 · WEEK 41

2 Samuel 20:1-22:51

Sheba's revolt; famine; David's song, the LORD is my rock

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 20:1-22:51. Sheba's rebellion is put down, and the narrative moves to an appendix that begins with David's long song of thanksgiving. Notice how the chapters end with praise.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After David's return, a worthless man named Sheba leads a revolt of the northern tribes, and Joab murders Amasa and puts it down. Chapters 21 to 24 form an appendix to the book, rather than a chronological narrative, and begin with a famine that David deals with, a list of warriors, and finally the song of chapter 22, which is the same as Psalm 18, which you read earlier.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Sheba says, "We have no portion in David, and we have no inheritance in the son of Jesse" (20:1).
2. Joab murders Amasa with a sword, and a wise woman of Abel saves her city by persuading the people to throw out Sheba's head (20:8-22).
3. A three-year famine comes because of Saul's bloodguilt against the Gibeonites, and David deals with it (21:1-14).
4. David's mighty men kill Philistine giants (21:15-22).
5. "The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge" (22:2-3).
6. "He reached down from on high, he took me; he drew me out of many waters" (22:17).

7. “This God, his way is perfect; the word of the LORD proves true” (22:31).
8. “Great salvation he brings to his king, and shows steadfast love to his anointed, to David and his offspring forever” (22:51).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The rebellion of Sheba is a short echo of Absalom’s. It shows that the unity of the kingdom is fragile. The cry, “We have no portion in David,” foreshadows the division that will follow Solomon (1 Kings 12:16). Even in David’s restoration, the seeds of the split are visible.

Chapter 21 is hard for modern readers. Saul had violated an ancient oath to the Gibeonites by trying to wipe them out. A famine follows, and David asks God. The solution involves the execution of seven of Saul’s descendants. The chapter shows that sins have long consequences, and that oaths made in God’s name are serious. It also shows David’s care for Jonathan’s son Mephibosheth, whom he spares for the sake of his oath, and his honor for the bones of Saul and Jonathan.

The list of David’s mighty men, and the stories of giants slain, remind us that the kingdom was won by the courage of many. David does not stand alone. He leads a band of faithful warriors. Yet when David grows weary, his men insist that he no longer go out to battle, “lest you quench the lamp of Israel” (21:17). The king’s life is precious because the nation depends on him.

Then comes the song. It is Psalm 18, placed here as a summary of David’s life. The editor of the book wanted readers to look back on everything that had happened and hear David’s own testimony: God rescued me. The song ends with the promise of an everlasting kingdom. The appendix begins with the rock and ends with the offspring of David forever.

The structure is intentional. Between the wars and the failures, the book wants us to see God’s faithfulness. The final word is steadfast love.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the “lamp” that does not go out (John 8:12), and the greater king who did not stay home from battle but went to the cross. Paul quotes 2 Samuel 22:50 in Romans 15:9 and applies it to Christ among the Gentiles. The theme of the one who is “rescued out of many waters” finds its fulfillment in the resurrection. Hebrews 11:32-34 recalls David among those who conquered through faith.

STEP 6

Application

Look back over your life and write your own short song of thanks, modeled on 2 Samuel 22.

Ask whether any promise or oath you have made needs to be kept.

Thank God for the people who fight alongside you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what he has been to you: rock, fortress, deliverer.

Thank him for rescuing you.

Thank him for steadfast love that has not left.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 41

"Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!"

PSALM 34:8

DAY 282 · WEEK 41

Psalm 34

I will bless the LORD at all times, taste and see

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 34. This is an acrostic psalm, each verse beginning with the next letter of the Hebrew alphabet. Read it as a testimony and a teaching.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The title says it was written "when he changed his behavior before Abimelech, so that he drove him out, and he went away." This refers to the time David feigned madness before King Achish of Gath (1 Samuel 21:10-15). Abimelech seems to be a title or alternate name. Having read that story, notice that David writes a psalm of praise about one of his most embarrassing moments. He saw the hand of God even in that.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will bless the LORD at all times; his praise shall continually be in my mouth" (v. 1).
2. "Oh, magnify the LORD with me, and let us exalt his name together!" (v. 3).
3. "I sought the LORD, and he answered me and delivered me from all my fears" (v. 4).
4. "This poor man cried, and the LORD heard him and saved him out of all his troubles" (v. 6).
5. "The angel of the LORD encamps around those who fear him, and delivers them" (v. 7).
6. "Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!" (v. 8).
7. "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted and saves the crushed in spirit" (v. 18).
8. "Many are the afflictions of the righteous, but the LORD delivers him out of them all" (v. 19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David turns an embarrassing escape into a hymn. He had acted like a madman, drooling on his beard, to avoid being killed. Yet he does not boast of his cleverness. He credits God: “This poor man cried, and the LORD heard him.” He calls himself poor. He knows he was saved by grace, not by his own wits.

The psalm moves from personal testimony to public invitation. “Magnify the LORD with me.” David wants others to share his joy. A good testimony is not just a story about what God did for me. It is an invitation to see God for who he is.

The famous line, “Taste and see that the LORD is good,” invites experience rather than argument. God is not only to be believed in but tasted. The psalm does not ask for blind faith. It points to the evidence of a life lived under God’s care, and it invites us to test it.

Verse 10 offers a striking contrast: “The young lions suffer want and hunger; but those who seek the LORD lack no good thing.” Lions are the strongest of predators, and yet they go hungry. Those who trust God, though weak, lack nothing that is truly good.

The center of the psalm’s teaching is verse 18: “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted.” It is one of the most comforting promises in the Bible. God is not distant from those who suffer. He is near. And verse 19 is honest: “Many are the afflictions of the righteous.” The psalm does not promise a life without trouble. It promises deliverance from it all.

The final verse offers a guarantee: “The LORD redeems the life of his servants; none of those who take refuge in him will be condemned.”

STEP 5

Connection

John 19:36 applies verse 20 to Jesus: “Not one of his bones will be broken.” Peter quotes verses 12 to 16 in 1 Peter 3:10-12 to teach Christians how to live. 1 Peter 2:3 echoes “taste and see” (“if indeed you have tasted that the Lord is good”). Jesus is the “angel of the LORD” fulfilled in the sense that he is near to those who are crushed (Matthew 11:28-30). Romans 8:1 says there is no condemnation for those in Christ Jesus.

STEP 6

Application

Turn an embarrassing or painful memory into a testimony of God’s help.

Today, “taste and see.” Look for a specific way that God shows his goodness.

Reach out to someone who is brokenhearted and be near to them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bless the LORD at this moment, in your own words.

Thank him for answering you in the past.

Pray for someone brokenhearted, and thank him that he is near.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 41

"Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!"

PSALM 34:8

DAY 283 · WEEK 41

Psalm 56; Psalm 57

When I am afraid I trust in you

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 56 and Psalm 57. Both come from David's fugitive years. Notice the repeated refrains and the confidence they reflect.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 56 is set "when the Philistines seized him in Gath," and Psalm 57 "when he fled from Saul, in the cave." Both carry the title Miktam, and both use the tune "Do Not Destroy." They are written in the narrowest places: a foreign city and a cave. Both end in a refrain of praise, which shows that faith can speak boldly even when circumstances are small and frightening.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When I am afraid, I put my trust in you" (56:3).
2. "In God, whose word I praise, in God I trust; I shall not be afraid. What can flesh do to me?" (56:4).
3. "You have kept count of my tossings; put my tears in your bottle. Are they not in your book?" (56:8).
4. "This I know, that God is for me" (56:9).
5. "Be merciful to me, O God, be merciful to me, for in you my soul takes refuge; in the shadow of your wings I will take refuge, till the storms of destruction pass by" (57:1).
6. "I cry out to God Most High, to God who fulfills his purpose for me" (57:2).
7. "My heart is steadfast, O God, my heart is steadfast! I will sing and make melody!" (57:7).
8. "Be exalted, O God, above the heavens! Let your glory be over all the earth!" (57:5, 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 56 gives a very honest account of fear. “When I am afraid.” It does not say “if.” David is afraid. He is in Gath, the home of Goliath, with the sword of Goliath in his hand. The psalm says that fear is a normal part of life, and the answer is not to deny it, but to bring it to God. “When I am afraid, I put my trust in you.” Courage in the Bible is not the absence of fear. It is trust in the midst of it.

The image of God collecting tears in a bottle has been loved for centuries. God does not just see our sorrow. He keeps count of our tossings and records our tears. Nothing is wasted. No tear falls unnoticed. It is among the most tender images in the Psalms.

And verse 9: “This I know, that God is for me.” It is a statement of settled conviction. It is the truth David holds to when he cannot see anything else. Paul would later write, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” (Romans 8:31).

Psalm 57 is set in a cave, but the cave becomes a place of high praise. “In the shadow of your wings I will take refuge, till the storms of destruction pass by.” It is a refuge for a season. David knows that the storm will pass. His confidence rests on God, “who fulfills his purpose for me.” God has a plan, and the cave cannot stop it.

The two refrains are lovely. Psalm 56 says, “In God I trust; I shall not be afraid.” Psalm 57 says, “Be exalted, O God, above the heavens!” In the first, trust is the response to fear. In the second, praise is the response to danger. Both turn the heart from circumstances to God.

Verse 8 of Psalm 57 is a morning song: “Awake, my glory! Awake, O harp and lyre! I will awake the dawn!” David wakes the dawn, rather than waiting for it.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus found refuge not in a cave but in his Father, who “collects” his tears (Hebrews 5:7). Paul quotes Psalm 56:4 in spirit in Romans 8:31 and Hebrews 13:6. Psalm 57:10 (“your steadfast love is great to the heavens”) echoes in Ephesians 3:18-19. Jesus said, “In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world” (John 16:33).

STEP 6

Application

Pray, “When I am afraid, I put my trust in you,” the next time you feel fear rising.

Remember that God keeps your tears in a bottle. None of them is wasted.

Wake the dawn with praise tomorrow morning, even if it is hard.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what makes you afraid, and say, “I trust you.”

Thank him that he keeps count of your tears.

Ask him to be exalted above your fears.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 41

“Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!”

PSALM 34:8

DAY 284 · WEEK 41

Psalm 30

I will extol you, O LORD, for you have drawn me up

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 30. It is a psalm of thanksgiving for being brought back from the edge of death. Notice how it moves from mourning to dancing.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The title reads, “A Psalm of David. A Song at the dedication of the temple.” The “house” may refer to David’s own palace, or to the temple site. In 2 Samuel 24 David numbers the people and faces a plague, which ended at the site where the temple would be built. Whatever the occasion, it is a psalm of a man who has come near to death and been raised.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “I will extol you, O LORD, for you have drawn me up and have not let my foes rejoice over me” (v. 1).
2. “O LORD my God, I cried to you for help, and you have healed me” (v. 2).
3. “O LORD, you have brought up my soul from Sheol; you restored me to life from among those who go down to the pit” (v. 3).
4. “For his anger is but for a moment, and his favor is for a lifetime. Weeping may tarry for the night, but joy comes with the morning” (v. 5).
5. “As for me, I said in my prosperity, I shall never be moved” (v. 6).
6. “You hid your face; I was dismayed” (v. 7).
7. “You have turned for me my mourning into dancing; you have loosed my sackcloth and clothed me with gladness” (v. 11).

8 “That my glory may sing your praise and not be silent. O LORD my God, I will give thanks to you forever!” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a story of three stages: security, crisis, and rescue. In the first, David was prosperous and said, “I shall never be moved.” He felt safe. But the security was in his prosperity rather than in God. Then God hid his face, and David was dismayed. The sudden loss of the sense of God’s presence showed him how much he depended on God. Third, he cried out, and God healed him.

The lesson is that comfort can breed complacency. When all is well, we can forget that we depend on God. Crises remind us. This is not a sentimental thought. David learned it by a frightening experience.

Verse 5 is one of the best-loved lines in the Psalter: “His anger is but for a moment, and his favor is for a lifetime. Weeping may tarry for the night, but joy comes with the morning.” It does not deny that the night is real. It says that the night will end. In the Bible, God’s discipline is brief compared to his kindness. The pain of this world is not the last word.

The reversal in verse 11 is a beautiful image. “You have turned for me my mourning into dancing.” It is God who does the turning. The sackcloth is loosed, and gladness is the new clothing. This is the pattern of the gospel: death becomes life, mourning becomes dancing.

The psalm ends with a purpose. God has done all this “that my glory may sing your praise and not be silent.” Our deliverance is meant to lead to worship. Silence is not an option for the one who has been rescued. David resolves to give thanks “forever.”

STEP 5

Connection

The movement from night to morning is the pattern of Easter. Jesus’ mourning disciples saw him alive on the third day (John 16:20-22; Luke 24). “Joy comes with the morning” echoes Mary at the tomb at dawn (John 20:1). Paul says, “For this light momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory” (2 Corinthians 4:17). Revelation 21:4 promises that mourning will pass away.

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on whether prosperity has made you too comfortable. Ask God to keep you dependent.

If you are in a night of weeping, hold on to verse 5 as a promise.

Think about how God has turned mourning into dancing in your own story, and share it with someone.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his anger is for a moment and his favor for a lifetime.

Tell him what mourning you want turned into dancing.

Give him praise for healing you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 41

"Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!"

PSALM 34:8

DAY 285 · WEEK 41

Psalm 35

Contend, O LORD, with those who contend with me

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 35. David asks God to defend him against false accusers. Read it as a prayer of someone who has been repaid evil for good.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 35 is a psalm of David, and it is one of the longest of his cries against enemies. It uses the language of the courtroom and the battlefield. It likely comes from the years of persecution under Saul, when David was accused unjustly and hunted. In the Bible, such prayers are not about private revenge but about asking God to act as judge and defender.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Contend, O LORD, with those who contend with me; fight against those who fight against me!” (v. 1).
2. “Say to my soul, I am your salvation!” (v. 3).
3. “For without cause they hid their net for me; without cause they dug a pit for my life” (v. 7).
4. “Then my soul will rejoice in the LORD, exulting in his salvation” (v. 9).
5. “All my bones shall say, O LORD, who is like you, delivering the poor from him who is too strong for him?” (v. 10).
6. “They repay me evil for good; my soul is bereft” (v. 12).
7. “But I, when they were sick, wore sackcloth; I afflicted myself with fasting; I prayed with head bowed on my chest” (vv. 13).

8 “Then my tongue shall tell of your righteousness and of your praise all the day long” (v. 28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with the call for God to fight. The language is of a defense attorney and of a soldier. David is asking the Lord to take his side. It is not private vengeance but an appeal to divine justice. He does not take up the sword himself. Instead, he asks God to act. We see this restraint in David’s behavior toward Saul.

At the heart of the request is verse 3: “Say to my soul, I am your salvation!” More than victory over enemies, David wants assurance that God is his. The deepest need in times of attack is to know that God is for us.

The center of the psalm is the contrast between how David treated his enemies and how they treated him. When they were sick, he wore sackcloth and fasted and prayed for them. Now they gather against him and mock. This is the hardest part: being repaid evil for good. “They repay me evil for good; my soul is bereft.” David feels deep grief at the unfairness, and he brings it to God.

This is the kind of pain that Jesus experienced. The psalm’s lines “without cause” and “they hated me without a cause” are quoted by Jesus in John 15:25 as fulfilled in him. He healed, taught, and served, and was repaid with hatred.

The psalm has three cycles, each ending with a vow of praise (verses 9 to 10, 18, and 27 to 28). In each, David moves from lament to anticipated thanksgiving. He ends by saying that his tongue will tell of God’s righteousness all day long. The pattern is a model for prayer in the face of injustice: tell God the truth, ask for his help, and promise to praise.

The imprecatory parts of the psalm, in which David asks for the shame of his enemies, should be read as a request that God’s justice would be done, and not as a license for personal hatred.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus quoted verse 19 in John 15:25: “They hated me without a cause.” He was falsely accused, mocked, and betrayed (Matthew 26:59-61). He answered with love and forgiveness (Luke 23:34). Paul teaches, “Bless those who persecute you; bless and do not curse” (Romans 12:14). 1 Peter 3:9 says, “Do not repay evil for evil… but on the contrary, bless.”

STEP 6

Application

If someone has repaid your kindness with cruelty, bring it to God in prayer rather than responding in kind.

Ask God to “say to your soul, I am your salvation.” Pause and listen.

Consider how you can pray for an enemy as David did when they were sick.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bring God your hurt about being repaid evil for good.

Ask him to help you bless and not curse.

Thank Jesus for being hated without cause.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 41

“Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!”

PSALM 34:8

DAY 286 · WEEK 41

Psalm 38; Psalm 39

Rebuke me not in your anger; show me, O LORD, my end

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 38 and Psalm 39. These are two of David's most honest prayers, about the suffering that comes with sin and with the brevity of life. Read them slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 38 is a penitential psalm, "for the memorial offering," and describes suffering in body and soul because of sin. Psalm 39 is a meditation on the shortness of life, written by a man who tried to hold his tongue and could not. They are placed together here after David's long reign and the sins and sorrows of the last chapters. Together they describe the weariness of a man who knows his frailty.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, rebuke me not in your anger, nor discipline me in your wrath!" (38:1).
2. "For my iniquities have gone over my head; like a heavy burden, they are too heavy for me" (38:4).
3. "I am utterly bowed down and prostrate; all the day I go about mourning" (38:6).
4. "O Lord, all my longing is before you; my sighing is not hidden from you" (38:9).
5. "For I hope in you, O LORD; it is you, O Lord my God, who will answer" (38:15).
6. "Make haste to help me, O Lord, my salvation!" (38:22).
7. "O LORD, make me know my end and what is the measure of my days; let me know how fleeting I am!" (39:4).
8. "And now, O Lord, for what do I wait? My hope is in you" (39:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 38 is a portrait of sin's weight. David feels it as a heavy burden, a pain in his body, and a mourning of his soul. His friends and neighbors stand aloof. He is aware of his guilt. And yet he does not despair. In the middle of the psalm, he says, "For I hope in you, O LORD." This is the same turn we have seen elsewhere: from the weight of the problem to the strength of the one who can solve it.

A significant line is verse 9: "All my longing is before you; my sighing is not hidden from you." God knows what we cannot put into words. A sigh is a prayer. There are times when we cannot form sentences, and the psalm assures us that God hears even our groans.

Psalm 39 begins with an attempt at silence. David determined to guard his mouth, so as not to sin with his tongue in the presence of the wicked. But the silence burned inside him, and finally he spoke. What he said was a prayer about the brevity of life.

"Make me know my end... let me know how fleeting I am!" It is a startling request. Most of us avoid thinking about death. David asks for awareness. "Behold, you have made my days a few handbreadths, and my lifetime is as nothing before you." Every person, even at his best, is a mere breath. This is not morbid. It is the beginning of wisdom. Moses prays the same in Psalm 90:12: "Teach us to number our days that we may get a heart of wisdom."

The turning point is verse 7: "And now, O Lord, for what do I wait? My hope is in you." If life is a breath, then everything depends on God. The question is where to place hope. David finds the answer in God alone.

The psalm ends in a plea for relief, with the confession that he is a sojourner with God, a guest on earth. Our time here is short. Our home is with him.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus carried our burden of sin: "He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree" (1 Peter 2:24). James 4:14 says, "You are a mist that appears for a little time and then vanishes." Psalm 39:12 is echoed in Hebrews 11:13 and 1 Peter 2:11, where believers are "sojourners and exiles." Paul says, "We look not to the things that are seen but to the things that are unseen" (2 Corinthians 4:18).

STEP 6

Application

Spend a few minutes asking God to "number your days." What would you do differently if you took your mortality seriously?

Bring a sigh to God today, something you cannot put into words.

Recall that you are a sojourner. Where have you been settling in too deeply?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to teach you to number your days.
- Tell him how heavy your iniquities feel and where your hope lies.
- Thank Jesus for carrying them.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 41

"Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!"

PSALM 34:8

DAY 287 · WEEK 41

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 34:8 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!"

PSALM 34:8

REST

Meditation

This verse is an invitation, not a command to believe on faith alone. David says, in effect, "Try it for yourself."

"Taste." You cannot know the flavor of food by reading about it. Tasting is personal and immediate. David is saying that the goodness of God is not only a doctrine. It is something we can experience. He had tasted it in the cave, in Gath, and in the wilderness. He asks us to do the same.

"And see." The tasting leads to seeing. What the Lord does is visible in the lives of those who trust him. This is the evidence David offers: not a philosophical argument, but a life.

"That the LORD is good." The goodness of God is the foundation of everything. He is not only powerful, or just, or wise, but good. When we are tempted to doubt, this is the claim we need most. God's goodness is not diminished by suffering. David wrote this psalm in a time of fear

and embarrassment.

“Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him.” The result of tasting is taking shelter. A person who knows that God is good will run to him. The word “blessed” echoes Psalm 1:1 and shows how David’s psalms continue the same theme.

Peter echoes this verse in 1 Peter 2:3: “If indeed you have tasted that the Lord is good.” The Lord is Jesus, and the tasting is personal. At the table of communion, we taste and see in a special way. Throughout the week, ask where you can taste his goodness: in answered prayer, in a kindness, in a beautiful day, in forgiveness.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed David in the aftermath of his sin. You prayed Psalm 51 with him and saw the pain in his family: Tamar’s suffering, Absalom’s revenge, and the rebellion that drove David from Jerusalem. You saw his humility as he walked out weeping, and how God worked through Hushai. You read the psalms of the wilderness, praising God’s steadfast love as better than life. You saw Absalom’s death and David’s grief, and the king’s restoration. In the appendix of 2 Samuel, David’s song looked back on God’s rescue. In Psalms 34, 56, 57, 30, 35, 38, and 39 you prayed with a man who knew fear, injustice, joy, and mortality. The week taught that God is near to the brokenhearted, that tears are never wasted, and that life is short but his goodness is not.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

David told his story of being rescued from a humiliating situation as a song of praise. What embarrassing or hard moment in your life could become a testimony of God’s help?

Psalm 34:18 says the LORD is near to the brokenhearted. How did Jesus, the Man of Sorrows, demonstrate that nearness, and how can you lean on it this week?

Psalm 39 asks God to teach us how brief life is. What would change in how you spend this week if you lived it with that awareness?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Taste and see: name one way you have seen God to be good this week.

Thank him for being near to the brokenhearted.

Thank Jesus, who knows your sorrows.

DAY 288 · WEEK 42

2 Samuel 23:1-24:25

David's last words; the mighty men; the census and plague

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 23:1-24:25. These are David's last words, the roll of his mighty men, and the story of the census and the plague. Notice how the book ends: with a sin, a sacrifice, and an altar.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The last chapters of 2 Samuel are an appendix, standing outside the main story. David speaks his final oracle, and the narrator lists his mighty men. Then comes an account of David numbering the people, a sin that brings a plague on Israel. The plague stops at the threshing floor of Araunah the Jebusite, where David builds an altar. This is the place where the temple will rise.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The oracle of David, the son of Jesse… the sweet psalmist of Israel" (23:1).
2. "The Spirit of the LORD speaks by me; his word is on my tongue" (23:2).
3. "When one rules justly over men, ruling in the fear of God, he dawns on them like the morning light, like the sun shining forth on a cloudless morning" (23:3-4).
4. "For does not my house stand so with God? For he has made with me an everlasting covenant, ordered in all things and secure" (23:5).
5. Three mighty men break through the Philistine camp to bring David water from Bethlehem, and he pours it out to the LORD (23:13-17).
6. David orders Joab to number the people, and afterward his heart strikes him: "I have sinned greatly in what I have done" (24:1-10).

7. David says, “Let us fall into the hand of the LORD, for his mercy is great; but let me not fall into the hand of man” (24:14).

8. “I will not offer to the LORD my God burnt offerings that cost me nothing” (24:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David’s last words are a reflection on kingship, and they sketch the portrait of the ideal king: one who rules justly in the fear of God. Such a king is like the morning light, like the sun after rain. The poem describes what David was meant to be and often was not. It is also an unwitting description of the coming Messiah. David says that God “has made with me an everlasting covenant, ordered in all things and secure.” At the end of his life, his hope is in the covenant, not in his own record.

The story of the three mighty men and the water from Bethlehem is a small gem. David longs for a drink from the well of his hometown. Three of his warriors risk their lives to get it. When they bring it, David will not drink. He pours it out to the LORD, saying that it is the blood of men who risked their lives. He sees their devotion as too holy to be consumed. It is a gesture of honor, and a sign that David understood the worth of sacrifice.

The census in chapter 24 is puzzling at first. Why was it a sin? The text does not say, but the likely issue is pride and self-reliance: counting the nation’s military strength as if the king’s power came from numbers. Even Joab sees the problem. David is struck in conscience and confesses. The prophet Gad offers three punishments, and David’s choice is a mark of his character: “Let us fall into the hand of the LORD, for his mercy is great.” Seventy thousand die. When the angel stretches out his hand over Jerusalem, “the LORD relented.”

David’s response is to buy the threshing floor and build an altar. “I will not offer burnt offerings that cost me nothing.” True worship involves cost. The plague stops, and the site becomes the temple mount (2 Chronicles 3:1). The book that began with a barren woman at a sanctuary ends with a king at an altar. A kingdom built on sacrifice and mercy.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the “sun shining forth on a cloudless morning” of righteous rule (Malachi 4:2; Luke 1:78-79). He is the king who does not count his strength in numbers but gives himself. The place where the plague stopped became the place of sacrifice, and the greater sacrifice at Jerusalem turned away God’s wrath for good (Romans 3:25; Hebrews 9:11-14). David’s refusal to offer what costs nothing is fulfilled in Christ, who gave everything.

STEP 6

Application

Ask if you are tempted to measure your security by numbers: income, followers, savings, or influence.

Think about what worship costs you. Is there anything you offer God that costs you nothing?

Pour out something precious to the LORD today, in gratitude.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from trusting in numbers or success.
- Thank him for an everlasting covenant secure in all things.
- Thank him for the altar where wrath was turned away.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 42

"Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!"

PSALM 72:19

DAY 289 · WEEK 42

1 Kings 1:1-2:46

Solomon established on the throne; David's final charge

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 85 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 1:1-2:46. David is old, and the question of who will succeed him comes to a head. Read David's charge to Solomon in chapter 2 with care.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first book of Kings opens with an elderly, cold David and a succession crisis. His son Adonijah declares himself king, but Nathan and Bathsheba persuade David to keep his promise that Solomon will reign. Solomon is anointed at Gihon. Before he dies, David gives Solomon a final charge. Then Solomon deals with those who threaten his throne.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Adonijah, "a very handsome man," says, "I will be king" (1:5-6).
2. Nathan and Bathsheba remind David of his oath that Solomon would reign (1:11-31).
3. Zadok the priest anoints Solomon with oil from the tent, and the people shout, "Long live King Solomon!" (1:38-40).
4. David's charge: "Be strong, and show yourself a man, and keep the charge of the LORD your God, walking in his ways" (2:2-3).
5. "That the LORD may establish his word that he spoke concerning me, saying, If your sons pay close attention to their way… you shall not lack a man on the throne of Israel" (2:4).
6. David dies: "Then David slept with his fathers and was buried in the city of David" (2:10).
7. Solomon has Adonijah, Joab, and Shimei dealt with (2:13-46).

8 “So the kingdom was established in the hand of Solomon” (2:46).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first chapters of Kings show the covenant of 2 Samuel 7 being worked out in real life. Adonijah’s bid for the throne follows the pattern of Absalom: a handsome prince, an entourage, and a claim made while the father is weak. But God has chosen Solomon, and God’s choice stands. Nathan, who spoke the covenant, and Bathsheba, who knows the promise, ensure that David’s oath is honored. The promise of God is kept through the quiet work of faithful people.

David’s last words to Solomon are the passage to read most carefully. They are a charge: “Keep the charge of the LORD your God, walking in his ways, and keeping his statutes… that you may prosper in all that you do.” The promise of the dynasty is tied to the obedience of the king. This is the pattern of the Davidic covenant as it unfolds: the promise of God is certain, but the individual kings who enjoy it must walk in faithfulness. It sets up the question the rest of Kings will answer: will the sons of David obey?

David also leaves Solomon some hard instructions about Joab and Shimei. These can read as vengeful, but David is passing on matters of justice that he had left unresolved. Joab had murdered Abner and Amasa. Shimei had cursed the king. Solomon, in his early reign, removes these threats. The narrative presents it as the establishment of the kingdom.

Notice the quiet line: “David slept with his fathers.” The man who was a shepherd, a fugitive, a king, an adulterer, a poet, and a penitent dies in peace. His reign lasted forty years. The kingdom now passes to his son.

The last line of the chapter is a hinge: “So the kingdom was established in the hand of Solomon.” It is a statement of fulfillment, and also a question about what will happen next.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the true Son of David who was anointed at the Jordan and cried, “It is finished.” Unlike Solomon, he needed no one to clear away his rivals. He conquered death by his own death. The charge to “be strong and keep the charge of the LORD” was kept perfectly only by him (Hebrews 3:6). Luke 22:29: “I assign to you, as my Father assigned to me, a kingdom.”

STEP 6

Application

If you are a parent or mentor, think about what charge you would leave to those who come after you.

Ask where you need to keep your word, as David did.

Thank God that the promised kingdom is established by Christ and not dependent on human obedience.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for keeping his promises through quiet and faithful people.

Ask him to help you walk in his ways.

Thank him for the true Son of David.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 42

"Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!"

PSALM 72:19

DAY 290 · WEEK 42

Psalm 45

My heart overflows, the royal wedding

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 45. This is a royal wedding song. Read it as a song for a king and his bride, and then read it again with the Messiah in mind.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The title calls it "A Maskil of the Sons of Korah, a love song," set to the tune "Lilies." It was probably composed for a royal wedding in Israel, perhaps even Solomon's. After the story of Solomon's accession, it is a fitting psalm to hear. But the language is so lofty that it was early read as pointing to the Messiah, and the New Testament quotes it that way.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "My heart overflows with a pleasing theme; I address my verses to the king; my tongue is like the pen of a ready scribe" (v. 1).
2. "You are the most handsome of the sons of men; grace is poured upon your lips; therefore God has blessed you forever" (v. 2).
3. "In your majesty ride out victoriously for the cause of truth and meekness and righteousness" (v. 4).
4. "Your throne, O God, is forever and ever. The scepter of your kingdom is a scepter of uprightness" (v. 6).
5. "You love righteousness and hate wickedness. Therefore God, your God, has anointed you with the oil of gladness beyond your companions" (v. 7).
6. "At your right hand stands the queen in gold of Ophir" (v. 9).

7. “Hear, O daughter, consider, and incline your ear: forget your people and your father’s house, and the king will desire your beauty” (vv. 10-11).

8. “I will cause your name to be remembered in all generations; therefore nations will praise you forever and ever” (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a love song, and it shows that the Bible is not embarrassed by joy at a wedding. The poet describes the king in glowing terms: handsome, gracious in speech, a warrior who rides out “for the cause of truth and meekness and righteousness.” The three words are unexpected for a king. A king who fights for truth, for meekness (humility), and righteousness is no ordinary monarch.

Then comes the surprise. The poet turns and addresses the king: “Your throne, O God, is forever and ever.” In the Hebrew, the king is addressed as “God.” Some readers have understood it as a figure of speech for the king’s godlike authority, but the line goes beyond the limits of any mere human king. The psalm raises a question that only the New Testament answers: who is this king whose throne is eternal and who is addressed as God?

The king is anointed “with the oil of gladness beyond your companions.” It is an echo of the Messiah’s anointing. And the king has a bride. In the second half of the psalm, the queen is told to forget her father’s house and to honor the king. She is given beautiful garments and brought in with joy. The picture of a royal marriage became, for the prophets and then the apostles, a picture of God’s covenant with his people.

The psalm ends with a promise that the king’s name will be remembered forever and that the nations will praise him. It is a promise that no human wedding could fulfill, but one that looks beyond to a king whose reign has no end.

Read in its original setting, it celebrates the royal house of David. Read in light of the whole Bible, it points to the wedding of the Lamb.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 1:8-9 quotes verses 6 and 7 and applies them directly to the Son: “But of the Son he says, Your throne, O God, is forever and ever.” The psalm is a witness to Christ’s deity. Paul describes the church as Christ’s bride (Ephesians 5:25-32), and Revelation 19:7-9 and 21:2 describe the marriage supper of the Lamb. John 3:29 says, “The one who has the bride is the bridegroom.”

STEP 6

Application

Read verses 6 and 7 aloud as praise to Jesus, whom Hebrews says is addressed here.

Think about how your relationship with Christ is like that of a bride with her husband.

Pray for the church, that she would be ready for the wedding.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what fills your heart when you think of Christ, the King.

Thank him that the King loves his bride, the church.

Ask him to make you faithful to the King.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 42

"Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!"

PSALM 72:19

DAY 291 · WEEK 42

Psalm 72

Give the king your justice, the ideal reign

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 72. It is a prayer for the king, and the only psalm attributed to Solomon in this section. Notice how much it says about justice for the poor, and how widely the king's rule extends.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The title says, "Of Solomon," and the last line says, "The prayers of David, the son of Jesse, are ended." It may be a prayer by David for his son, or a prayer for Solomon at his accession. It closes Book II of the Psalter. The psalm describes what a king should be, and in doing so, reaches far beyond anything Solomon could achieve. It describes the Messiah.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give the king your justice, O God, and your righteousness to the royal son!" (v. 1).
2. "May he judge your people with righteousness, and your poor with justice!" (v. 2).
3. "May he defend the cause of the poor of the people, give deliverance to the children of the needy, and crush the oppressor!" (v. 4).
4. "May they fear you while the sun endures, and as long as the moon, throughout all generations!" (v. 5).
5. "May he be like rain that falls on the mown grass, like showers that water the earth!" (v. 6).
6. "May he have dominion from sea to sea, and from the River to the ends of the earth!" (v. 8).
7. "For he delivers the needy when he calls, the poor and him who has no helper" (v. 12).

8 “May his name endure forever, his fame continue as long as the sun! May people be blessed in him, all nations call him blessed!” (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The prayer begins with a request that the king would have God’s own justice. The king does not make justice. He receives it from God. A good ruler is one who reflects the character of the LORD. And the first test of justice, in this psalm, is how the poor are treated. The king is called to defend the poor, deliver the needy, and crush the oppressor. The word “poor” appears again and again. In the Bible, a ruler’s quality is measured by what happens to the weakest.

The next image is a beautiful one: the king’s rule as rain on mown grass. After the harvest, the field is cut short and dry, and rain brings new growth. A righteous king revives the land. Justice brings flourishing.

The psalm’s scope is large. “From sea to sea.” “To the ends of the earth.” “Kings bow down to him.” This is a vision of universal rule, and it reflects the promise to Abraham that all nations would be blessed (Genesis 12:3). In the last verses, we hear the promise echoed: “May people be blessed in him, all nations call him blessed!”

Solomon’s reign did not match this ideal. It began with promise, but it ended in oppression, taxation, and idolatry. The psalm remained a prayer waiting for an answer. The people kept praying for the king who would fulfill it.

The final doxology, “Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, who alone does wondrous things,” closes the second book of the Psalms. It leaves the reader with the sense that this prayer is not finished. “May the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the king who defends the poor (Luke 4:18; 6:20), who delivers the needy who cry to him, and whose rule will reach “from sea to sea.” The wise men from the East brought gifts and bowed down (Matthew 2:11). Philippians 2:10-11 says every knee will bow. Galatians 3:8 shows the blessing of Abraham reaching the nations. Revelation 21:24-26 pictures the kings of the earth bringing glory into the city.

STEP 6

Application

Ask how you treat the poor, the needy, and those without influence. What does the psalm ask of you?

Pray this psalm for the leaders of your nation, and for the reign of Christ.

Pray “May the whole earth be filled with his glory” for a specific place or people.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pray for justice for the poor and needy.
- Thank Jesus, who defends them.
- Pray that all nations would come to know him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 42

“Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!”

PSALM 72:19

DAY 292 · WEEK 42

1 Kings 3:1-5:18

Solomon's wisdom; the golden age begins

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 3:1-5:18. Solomon asks for wisdom, shows it in the case of the two women, and builds a flourishing kingdom. Notice both the glory and the small warnings.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Solomon's reign begins with a political marriage to Pharaoh's daughter and with worship at the high places, which are small signs that things are not perfect. At Gibeon, God appears to him in a dream and offers him whatever he asks. These chapters show the fulfillment of the promise to Abraham: a peaceful, prosperous Israel with influence over the nations. Solomon prepares to build the temple.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Solomon marries Pharaoh's daughter, and "only, the people were sacrificing at the high places" (3:1-3).
2. God says, "Ask what I shall give you" (3:5).
3. Solomon answers, "I am but a little child. I do not know how to go out or come in... Give your servant therefore an understanding mind to govern your people, that I may discern between good and evil" (3:7-9).
4. "It pleased the Lord that Solomon had asked this" (3:10). God gives wisdom, riches, and honor (3:11-14).
5. Two women claim the same baby, and Solomon proposes to divide it. The true mother says, "Give her the living child" (3:16-28).

6. “Judah and Israel were as many as the sand by the sea. They ate and drank and were happy” (4:20).
7. “God gave Solomon wisdom and understanding beyond measure, like the sand on the seashore” (4:29).
8. Solomon writes 3,000 proverbs and 1,005 songs, and people come from all nations to hear his wisdom (4:32-34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Solomon’s prayer at Gibeon is a model of humility. He calls himself a little child, aware of his inadequacy. He asks not for wealth, or long life, or the death of enemies, but for an understanding heart. God is pleased, and gives him what he asked and what he did not. The principle is stated elsewhere in the Bible: “Seek first the kingdom of God… and all these things will be added to you” (Matthew 6:33).

The story of the two women shows what the wisdom looks like in practice. It is not abstract. It is the ability to see through a deadlock and reveal the truth. “All Israel heard of the judgment that the king had rendered, and they stood in awe of the king, because they perceived that the wisdom of God was in him.” Wisdom from God allows a ruler to administer justice.

Chapter 4 describes the kingdom at its height. The people are as many as the sand by the sea, and “each man under his vine and under his fig tree.” It is the fulfillment of the promise to Abraham and a taste of the peace that God wants for his people. The description of Solomon’s wisdom is stunning: greater than that of all the people of the East. Nations send ambassadors.

But there are quiet warnings, if you read carefully. The marriage alliance with Egypt, the lingering practice of high places, and the long lists of provisions all hint at a king who is gathering what Deuteronomy 17 told kings not to gather: wives, horses, and wealth. The text does not tell us this yet, but it plants the question.

The treaty with Hiram of Tyre in chapter 5 prepares for the temple. It also shows the cost: forced labor. “King Solomon drafted forced labor out of all Israel.” The shadow of oppression begins.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is “greater than Solomon” (Matthew 12:42). He is the wisdom of God (1 Corinthians 1:24, 30), and in him are “hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge” (Colossians 2:3). James 1:5 says, “If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask God, who gives generously to all without reproach.” The peace of Solomon’s reign points to the peace that Christ brings (Ephesians 2:14).

STEP 6

Application

Pray Solomon’s prayer today. Ask for an understanding mind to do what God has given you to do.

Notice what you ask God for most often. What does that reveal?

Look for the quiet warnings in your own life, small compromises that seem harmless now.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God for an understanding mind and a discerning heart.
- Thank him for Jesus, the wisdom of God, greater than Solomon.
- Ask him to keep you from small compromises.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 42

“Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!”

PSALM 72:19

DAY 293 · WEEK 42

1 Kings 6:1-7:51

The Temple built, the permanent dwelling of God

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 101 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 6:1-7:51. The temple is built. Read the details as a description of a house for God's presence, and watch for the note in 6:11-13, where God speaks.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Solomon begins to build the temple in the fourth year of his reign, 480 years after the exodus. The temple is on Mount Moriah, the threshing floor David had purchased. The design follows that of the tabernacle but is larger and more permanent. The chapters also describe Solomon's palace and the bronze work of Hiram. It was a seven-year project.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In the four hundred and eightieth year after the people of Israel came out of the land of Egypt… he began to build the house of the LORD" (6:1).
2. The stones were prepared at the quarry, "so that neither hammer nor axe nor any tool of iron was heard in the house while it was being built" (6:7).
3. God's word comes to Solomon: "Concerning this house that you are building, if you will walk in my statutes… then I will establish my word with you, which I spoke to David your father" (6:11-13).
4. "And I will dwell among the children of Israel and will not forsake my people Israel" (6:13).
5. The inner sanctuary, the Most Holy Place, is a cube, overlaid with gold, with two cherubim of olive wood (6:19-28).
6. The walls are carved with cherubim, palm trees, and open flowers (6:29-35).

7. “He was seven years in building it” (6:38).
8. Solomon spent thirteen years building his own house (7:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The temple is a work of extraordinary care. Even its construction was done in reverence: stones cut at the quarry, so that no hammering was heard at the site. It reflects the holiness of the place. The temple’s carvings of cherubim, palm trees, and open flowers recall the garden of Eden. The temple is a miniature Eden: a place where God dwells with his people. The Most Holy Place, a perfect cube covered in gold, is later echoed in the New Jerusalem (Revelation 21:16).

In the middle of the building account, God speaks. It is a short but important interruption. The temple is not enough. The building is secondary to obedience. “If you will walk in my statutes… then I will establish my word with you.” The promise of dwelling among them is tied to faithfulness. The temple could not save Israel if they were not obedient. This is the theme the prophets would later echo (Jeremiah 7:4).

The detail that it took seven years to build the temple and thirteen to build his own house is probably a quiet comment. The narrator does not accuse. But the contrast gives the reader pause. Where do a king’s priorities lie? Over time, the palace would grow while devotion declined.

The bronze work of Hiram, with the two pillars Jachin and Boaz, the sea, and the ten basins, shows the grandeur. The pillars’ names mean “he establishes” and “in him is strength.” They stood at the entrance as a statement about where Israel’s security lay.

The temple is a beautiful thing. But the people of God needed to learn that God does not live in houses made with hands. He chose to dwell there, but he cannot be contained by it.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the true temple (John 2:19-21), the place where God dwells with man (John 1:14). Believers are now God’s temple, built together into a dwelling place for God by the Spirit (1 Corinthians 3:16; Ephesians 2:21-22). Stephen reminded his hearers that “the Most High does not dwell in houses made by hands” (Acts 7:48). Revelation 21:22 says of the New Jerusalem, “I saw no temple in the city, for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb.”

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on the proportion between how much you invest in your own house and in God’s.

Remember that you are now a temple of the Holy Spirit. How does that shape how you live?

Thank God for the Eden-like promise of dwelling with his people.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for making his dwelling with his people.

Thank him that you are a dwelling place for his Spirit.

Ask him to keep you from building your own house before his.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 42

"Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!"

PSALM 72:19

DAY 294 · WEEK 42

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 72:19 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!"

PSALM 72:19

REST

Meditation

This verse ends the second book of the Psalms with a burst of praise. It follows the long prayer for the king and carries the hope of the whole psalm into a doxology.

"Blessed be his glorious name forever." To bless the name of God is to speak well of him, to honor him as he deserves. His name is his character and reputation, everything about him that has been revealed. The word "forever" is the language of eternity: not for a moment, not for a lifetime, but without end.

"May the whole earth be filled with his glory!" This is one of the Bible's great prayers. It echoes Numbers 14:21, where God says, "All the earth shall be filled with the glory of the LORD." It anticipates Habakkuk 2:14. It is the purpose of creation and redemption: that the glory of God would cover the earth as the waters cover the sea.

“Amen and Amen!” The double Amen is an emphatic “Let it be so.” It is the people’s agreement. They are not spectators but participants.

The context matters. This psalm is a prayer for a king, and the verse puts the king’s reign in its place. The king’s task is not to build his own name but to serve a purpose bigger than himself: the glory of God in all the earth. Solomon did not achieve this. His kingdom faded, and his temple fell. But the prayer remained, and it points to a king who will.

For the Christian, this is a prayer for the coming of Christ’s kingdom. When we pray “Hallowed be your name, your kingdom come,” we pray the same thing. And we live for it: that the earth would be filled with his glory. Let this be the prayer of your heart.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week the Davidic story reached its end and the Solomonic age began. You read David’s last words and his oracle of the just king, and the sobering account of the census and the plague, which ended at the threshing floor that would become the temple mount. You saw Solomon anointed and David’s charge to him, and you watched Solomon ask for wisdom and show it. You read of the building of the temple, a miniature Eden where God would dwell. In the Psalms, you read the royal wedding song of Psalm 45, which Hebrews applies to the Son, and Psalm 72, the prayer for the king that no human king could answer. The week taught that David’s hope rested on an everlasting covenant, that wisdom is a gift from God, and that the temple, though glorious, pointed to a greater dwelling.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

David refused to offer God what cost him nothing. What does faithful worship cost you, and what are you tempted to hold back?

Hebrews says Psalm 45 is addressed to the Son: “Your throne, O God, is forever and ever.” How does it change your view of Jesus to hear him addressed this way?

Solomon asked for wisdom, and God gave him more. Where do you need wisdom this week, and how will you ask for it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bless God’s glorious name and pray for the earth to be filled with his glory.

Thank him for the King who judges with righteousness.

Rest in him today.

DAY 295 · WEEK 43

1 Kings 8:1-66

The Temple dedicated; Solomon's great prayer

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 8:1-66. This is the dedication of the temple, and Solomon's great prayer. Read the prayer slowly, and notice how often he asks God to hear and forgive.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The temple is complete, and the ark is brought in. The glory of the LORD fills the house in a cloud, as it filled the tabernacle in Exodus 40. Solomon blesses the people and offers a long prayer of dedication. He asks God to hear the prayers offered toward the temple, whatever the circumstances, and to forgive. The feast ends with enormous sacrifices and joy.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The priests bring the ark into the Most Holy Place, "and when the priests came out of the Holy Place, a cloud filled the house of the LORD" (8:6-10).
2. "For the glory of the LORD filled the house of the LORD" (8:11).
3. "The LORD has said that he would dwell in thick darkness. I have built you an exalted house, a place for you to dwell in forever" (8:12-13).
4. "O LORD, God of Israel, there is no God like you, in heaven above or on earth beneath, keeping covenant and showing steadfast love to your servants who walk before you with all their heart" (8:23).
5. "But will God indeed dwell on the earth? Behold, heaven and the highest heaven cannot contain you; how much less this house that I have built!" (8:27).
6. "Hear in heaven your dwelling place, and when you hear, forgive" (8:30).
7. "For there is no one who does not sin" (8:46).

8 “That all the peoples of the earth may know that the LORD is God; there is no other” (8:60).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The cloud that fills the temple is a sign that God has accepted the house. It echoes the glory at Sinai and in the wilderness tabernacle. The priests cannot stand to minister. The reality of God’s presence overwhelms them. This is the high point of the temple’s history. It is the moment when the dream of God dwelling with his people seemed to come true.

Solomon’s prayer is a masterpiece of theology. It starts with praise: there is no God like you, who keeps covenant and shows steadfast love. It acknowledges that God has kept his promise to David. And then comes the great honesty of verse 27: “Will God indeed dwell on the earth? Heaven and the highest heaven cannot contain you; how much less this house.” Solomon knows that the temple does not limit God. It is a place where God chooses to put his name, not a box that holds him.

The heart of the prayer is a series of seven situations: wrong done between neighbors, defeat in war, drought, famine and plague, the foreigner who comes, battle, and exile. In each, Solomon asks God to hear in heaven and forgive. The temple becomes a house of prayer. The assumption throughout is that the people will sin: “There is no one who does not sin.” The temple, then, is above all a place of forgiveness. It is where sacrifice is offered, where sins are atoned, and where the lost may turn back.

Verses 41 to 43 are a remarkable window: the foreigner who comes from a far country “for your name’s sake” is to be heard, “that all the peoples of the earth may know your name.” The temple was meant to be a light to the nations.

The dedication ends with a benediction and a feast of fellowship offerings. “The people went to their homes joyful and glad of heart for all the goodness that the LORD had shown to David his servant and to Israel his people.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the true dwelling of God, the glory in the flesh (John 1:14). He is greater than the temple (Matthew 12:6). On the cross, the temple curtain was torn, opening the way into the presence of God (Matthew 27:51; Hebrews 10:19-22). He called the temple “a house of prayer for all nations” (Mark 11:17). Acts 2 shows the Spirit filling the church, as the glory once filled the house.

STEP 6

Application

Pray the pattern of Solomon's prayer: praise, honest confession, and a request for forgiveness.

Remember that God cannot be contained by any building. Where do you try to confine him?

Pray for someone from another nation to come to know the name of the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God that heaven cannot contain him and yet he dwells with his people.
- Tell him what you want him to hear and forgive.
- Thank Jesus, the true temple.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 43

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 296 · WEEK 43

Psalm 48

Great is the LORD in the city of our God

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 48. It is a song of Zion, the city of God. Imagine walking around Jerusalem, counting its towers, and giving thanks for God's protection.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 48 is a song of the sons of Korah and one of the Songs of Zion (see also Psalms 46, 76, 84, 87, 122). Written to celebrate God's deliverance of Jerusalem, perhaps from a military threat, it praises the city as the place of God's presence. Following the dedication of the temple, it is a fitting song for the pilgrims who came to worship there.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Great is the LORD and greatly to be praised in the city of our God! His holy mountain, beautiful in elevation, is the joy of all the earth" (vv. 1-2).
2. "Mount Zion, in the far north, the city of the great King" (v. 2).
3. "Within her citadels God has made himself known as a fortress" (v. 3).
4. "For behold, the kings assembled; they came on together. As soon as they saw it, they were astounded" (vv. 4-5).
5. "As we have heard, so have we seen in the city of the LORD of hosts" (v. 8).
6. "We have thought on your steadfast love, O God, in the midst of your temple" (v. 9).
7. "Walk about Zion, go around her, number her towers, consider well her ramparts" (vv. 12-13).
8. "That you may tell the next generation that this is God, our God forever and ever. He will guide us forever" (vv. 13-14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a declaration of the greatness of God, and then celebrates the city where he lives. Zion is called beautiful in elevation, the joy of all the earth. It is not praised because of its architecture or defenses, but because of who lives there. “God has made himself known as a fortress” within her. The city’s security is the LORD himself.

The picture of the kings assembling and being astounded is dramatic. They see the city and flee in panic. It does not describe a human victory. They are overcome by the sight of God’s presence. The psalm echoes the stories of Jerusalem’s deliverance, perhaps in the days of Jehoshaphat or Hezekiah.

Verse 9 gives the center: “We have thought on your steadfast love, O God, in the midst of your temple.” The temple is not a source of national pride. It is a place to meditate on the covenant love of God. And that praise reaches “to the ends of the earth.”

The psalm then gives a unique invitation: “Walk about Zion, go around her, number her towers.” Pilgrims are told to go around the city and look carefully, as if to say, “Check for yourself. Count the towers.” The purpose is not tourism. It is so that “you may tell the next generation that this is God, our God forever and ever.” The tour is for the sake of testimony. Remembering what God has done is a duty to the young.

The psalm ends with a promise: “He will guide us forever.” The God who lives in Zion is not just a defender but a guide. The psalm makes the city a symbol of the permanent protection of God’s people.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 12:22-24 says that believers have come “to Mount Zion and to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem,” and to Jesus. Matthew 5:35 calls Jerusalem “the city of the great King.” Revelation 21 describes the New Jerusalem coming down from heaven, safe forever. Jesus said he would build his church, and the gates of hell would not prevail against it (Matthew 16:18).

STEP 6

Application

Walk around your own “Zion” in your mind and count what God has done for your church and family. Tell it to someone younger.

Ask where you are depending on your own towers rather than on God.

Meditate on God’s steadfast love in prayer or in worship this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God, in your own words, for being great.

Tell him what you have thought on of his steadfast love.

Ask him to help you tell someone younger that this is God.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 43

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 297 · WEEK 43

Psalm 84

How lovely is your dwelling place

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 84. It is a pilgrim's song, a longing for the courts of the LORD. Read it slowly and notice the happy people it describes.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 84 is a psalm of the sons of Korah, who were temple singers and doorkeepers. It is a song for pilgrims traveling to Jerusalem for one of the feasts, probably Tabernacles. It is among the most beloved psalms of all time. Following the dedication of the temple and the song of Zion, it expresses the deep desire of the heart to be where God is.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "How lovely is your dwelling place, O LORD of hosts!" (v. 1).
2. "My soul longs, yes, faints for the courts of the LORD; my heart and flesh sing for joy to the living God" (v. 2).
3. "Even the sparrow finds a home, and the swallow a nest for herself, where she may lay her young, at your altars" (v. 3).
4. "Blessed are those who dwell in your house, ever singing your praise!" (v. 4).
5. "Blessed are those whose strength is in you, in whose heart are the highways to Zion" (v. 5).
6. "As they go through the Valley of Baca they make it a place of springs" (v. 6).
7. "For a day in your courts is better than a thousand elsewhere. I would rather be a doorkeeper in the house of my God than dwell in the tents of wickedness" (v. 10).

8 “For the LORD God is a sun and shield; the LORD bestows favor and honor. No good thing does he withhold from those who walk uprightly” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with exclamation. “How lovely!” It is not a calm analysis but an outburst of longing. The poet’s soul “faints” for the temple. “My heart and flesh sing for joy to the living God.” Worship is not merely duty. It is joy and desire. The psalm teaches us to want what we ought to want.

The sparrow and the swallow are a charming picture. Even the smallest birds make their homes near the altar. The poet envies them. They live in the presence of God. It is an image of belonging: the smallest and least can find a home in God’s house.

Then come two beatitudes. First, “Blessed are those who dwell in your house.” Second, “Blessed are those whose strength is in you, in whose heart are the highways to Zion.” The second is subtle. The pilgrim has the roads to Zion in his heart. Even when he is far away, his heart is already traveling. A heart set on pilgrimage makes the journey a blessing.

“As they go through the Valley of Baca they make it a place of springs.” Baca means “weeping.” The pilgrim route passes through a dry valley, a place of sorrow. But those who go with their hearts set on God transform the valley into springs. Suffering becomes a source of refreshment. And “they go from strength to strength.” The pilgrimage is a journey in which strength grows.

The famous tenth verse puts it simply: “A day in your courts is better than a thousand elsewhere.” The poet would rather be a doorkeeper, the lowest servant, at God’s house than live in luxury elsewhere. Being near God is the greatest good. The psalm ends with a promise: “No good thing does he withhold from those who walk uprightly.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the sun and shield, and the true dwelling place (John 1:14; Malachi 4:2). He said, “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden” (Matthew 11:28). In him, believers have access to the Father (Ephesians 2:18; Hebrews 10:19-22). Romans 8:32 echoes verse 11: “He who did not spare his own Son but gave him up for us all, how will he not also with him graciously give us all things?” Philippians 3:8-14 shows Paul pressing on to know Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you long for God’s presence. If not, ask him to give you the desire.

When you walk through your own “Valley of Baca,” consider how God may turn it into springs.

Meet with God’s people this week, and treat it as a gift.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what your soul longs for.
- Ask him to make your strength be in him.
- Say aloud that a day in his courts is better than a thousand elsewhere.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 43

“And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever.”

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 298 · WEEK 43

Psalm 87

Glorious things of you are spoken, O city of God

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 87. This short psalm is a song about Zion and the nations. Read it slowly. It makes a surprising claim about who belongs to God's city.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 87 is another psalm of the sons of Korah and another song of Zion. It is only seven verses, and it is one of the most unusual psalms. It names the great enemies of Israel (Rahab, Babylon, Philistia, Tyre, Cush) and declares that people from these nations will be counted as born in Zion. It looks forward to the day the nations share in the blessing of God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "On the holy mount stands the city he founded" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD loves the gates of Zion more than all the dwelling places of Jacob" (v. 2).
3. "Glorious things of you are spoken, O city of God" (v. 3).
4. "Among those who know me I mention Rahab and Babylon; behold, Philistia and Tyre, with Cush: This one was born there" (v. 4).
5. "And of Zion it shall be said, This one and that one were born in her" (v. 5).
6. "For the Most High himself will establish her" (v. 5).
7. "The LORD records as he registers the peoples, This one was born there" (v. 6).
8. "Singers and dancers alike say, All my springs are in you" (v. 7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This psalm turns expectations upside down. Rahab is a poetic name for Egypt. Babylon, Philistia, Tyre, and Cush are the major powers around Israel, and most of them were Israel's enemies. In the psalm, God says that he will count them among "those who know me." People from those nations will be said to have been born in Zion.

Being "born in Zion" means being a full citizen, a native of God's city. The psalm imagines the LORD keeping a register. As he reads the list, he says of Egyptians, Babylonians, Philistines, and Ethiopians, "This one was born there." It is a vision of grace beyond Israel. The people who were enemies become citizens of the city of God. The wall of separation is broken.

Why is this so important? It reflects the promise to Abraham that all nations would be blessed (Genesis 12:3). It anticipates the prophets, who spoke of the nations streaming to Zion (Isaiah 2:2-3). The Davidic covenant was not simply for Israel's benefit. God's purpose was a family drawn from every nation.

The last verse ties it together. "All my springs are in you." The singers and dancers find all their joy in Zion. For those who are born there, it is the source of life itself.

This psalm shows how the Old Testament prepares for the gospel. It is not a late idea that the nations are welcome. It was always God's plan. When Peter and Paul preach to the Gentiles, they are fulfilling what psalms like this foretold.

STEP 5

Connection

Galatians 4:26 speaks of "the Jerusalem above" as our mother. Ephesians 2:19 says, "You are no longer strangers and aliens, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God." Jesus said, "You must be born again" (John 3:7). Philippians 3:20 says, "Our citizenship is in heaven." Revelation 7:9 pictures a multitude from every nation standing before the throne.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God that you are a citizen of his city, whatever your background.

Ask whether you have drawn lines around who belongs. Is there a group you consider an outsider?

Pray for a nation that seems far from God, that people from it would be counted as born in Zion.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for counting you as born in Zion.

Ask him to make you welcoming to those who are far off.

Pray that people from every nation would belong to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 43

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 299 · WEEK 43

Psalm 101

I will sing of steadfast love and justice, David's royal vow

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 101. David describes the kind of king he intends to be. Read it as a vow, and ask how it applies to anyone who has influence over others.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 101 is a psalm of David, and it reads like a king's inaugural pledge. He promises to rule with integrity, to avoid evil in his house, and to remove the wicked from the city. In the sequence of this unit, it comes after the temple is built and before the story of Solomon's downfall. David's vow stands in contrast to what Solomon will become.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will sing of steadfast love and justice; to you, O LORD, I will make music" (v. 1).
2. "I will ponder the way that is blameless. Oh when will you come to me? I will walk with integrity of heart within my house" (v. 2).
3. "I will not set before my eyes anything that is worthless" (v. 3).
4. "The one who has a haughty look and an arrogant heart I will not endure" (v. 5).
5. "I will look with favor on the faithful in the land, that they may dwell with me; he who walks in the way that is blameless shall minister to me" (v. 6).
6. "No one who practices deceit shall dwell in my house; no one who utters lies shall continue before my eyes" (v. 7).
7. "Morning by morning I will destroy all the wicked in the land" (v. 8).
8. "Cutting off all the evildoers from the city of the LORD" (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with praise, not boasting. “I will sing of steadfast love and justice.” The twin themes of God’s own character become the foundation of David’s kingship. A king must reflect both love and justice. If either is missing, the rule fails.

The heart of the psalm is the integrity of the king’s own life. “I will walk with integrity of heart within my house.” Before David concerns himself with the nation, he concerns himself with the household. Private character comes first. A person’s integrity is tested where no one sees. “I will not set before my eyes anything that is worthless.” It is a commitment to guard what he looks at, an important thought for a man who fell through what he saw from his roof.

David then describes the kind of people he will have around him. He will not tolerate slander or arrogance. He will look for the faithful and honor them. A leader’s choice of associates shapes his rule. He will not let deceit dwell in his house.

The language of the closing verse may seem harsh, “Morning by morning I will destroy all the wicked,” but it refers to the king’s duty to administer justice, to purge evil from the community. The “morning by morning” recalls the daily court sessions held at the city gate.

We know that David did not live up to this vow. His sin with Bathsheba, his failure with his sons, and the rest of the story show that he fell short. And Solomon, who inherited the throne, would let deceit, idolatry, and compromise into his house. The psalm stands as an ideal that no human king achieved. It is an unfulfilled vow waiting for the king who would.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the king whose life matches this vow. He walked in the way that is blameless (Hebrews 4:15), and he will one day remove all evil from his kingdom (Matthew 13:41; Revelation 21:27). He looks with favor on the faithful (Matthew 25:21). Paul says that Christians should guard their eyes and hearts (Philippians 4:8). 1 John 2:16 warns about “the desires of the eyes.”

STEP 6

Application

Make a small vow like David’s about what you will not set before your eyes.

Reflect on how your integrity at home compares with your public self.

Consider who you allow near you as friends and advisers.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you walk with integrity at home.
- Ask him to guard what you set before your eyes.
- Confess where you have fallen short, and ask for help.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 43

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 300 · WEEK 43

1 Kings 9:1-11:43

God's warning; Solomon's foreign wives; the kingdom fractures

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 99 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 9:1-11:43. God appears to Solomon a second time with a warning. Then the story shows Solomon's wealth, his many wives, and his fall into idolatry. Read chapter 11 with care. It is the end of the unit's story.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the temple's dedication, God appears to Solomon with a conditional promise and a warning. The following chapters describe Solomon's accomplishments: cities, ships, the visit of the Queen of Sheba, and enormous wealth. Then, in chapter 11, the narrator gives a sad accounting of Solomon's heart. The kingdom that began with wisdom ends in compromise. God announces the division of the kingdom, but for David's sake, not all of it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God says, "If you will walk before me, as David your father walked… then I will establish your royal throne over Israel forever" (9:4-5).
2. "But if you turn aside from following me… then I will cut off Israel from the land" (9:6-7).
3. The Queen of Sheba says, "The half was not told me. Your wisdom and prosperity surpass the report that I heard" (10:7).
4. "Blessed be the LORD your God, who has delighted in you" (10:9).
5. Solomon's gold: 666 talents a year, ivory, horses, and chariots (10:14-29).
6. "King Solomon loved many foreign women… he had 700 wives, who were princesses, and 300 concubines. And his wives turned away his heart" (11:1-3).

7. “His heart was not wholly true to the LORD his God, as was the heart of David his father” (11:4).

8. “Because you have done this… I will tear the kingdom from you… However, I will not do it in your days, for the sake of David your father… I will give one tribe to your son, for the sake of David my servant” (11:11-13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

God’s second appearance to Solomon repeats the pattern of the covenant: the promise is sure, but the individual’s blessing depends on obedience. “If you will walk before me… I will establish your throne. But if you turn aside… Israel will become a proverb and a byword among all peoples.” It is a clear warning, delivered right after the temple’s dedication.

Chapter 10 shows the glory. The Queen of Sheba comes from far away to test Solomon with hard questions. She is overwhelmed. Her response is one of the most moving praises in Kings: “Blessed be the LORD your God, who has delighted in you.” The nations are drawn to the wisdom of Israel’s king. For a moment, it looks as though the promise to Abraham is being fulfilled.

But the details are ominous. “Gold, ivory, horses from Egypt.” Deuteronomy 17:16-17 had warned the king not to acquire many horses, wives, or silver and gold. Solomon does all three. The narrator lists them with growing weight. What looks like prosperity is the accumulation of what he was told to avoid.

Chapter 11 is the tragic center. Solomon loved many foreign women, and they turned his heart away to other gods. The wisest man in Israel is a fool for love. He builds high places for Chemosh and Molech. “His heart was not wholly true to the LORD.” It is not that he stops believing in the LORD, but that he divides his heart. Divided loyalty is a form of idolatry.

God’s judgment is real: the kingdom will be torn. But even here, mercy shines. Not in Solomon’s lifetime, “for the sake of David,” and not the whole kingdom, “for the sake of Jerusalem which I have chosen.” God’s covenant with David is the reason the line continues. The promise holds, not because of Solomon’s merit, but because of God’s faithfulness.

The unit ends with a question the whole Old Testament will keep asking: if even Solomon fails, who can be the king God promised?

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the king who did not divide his heart, who resisted every temptation (Matthew 4:1-11), and whose wisdom exceeds Solomon's (Matthew 12:42). He is the true Son of David who will never fall. Where Solomon was led astray by foreign wives, the church is the bride of Christ, kept faithful by his grace (Ephesians 5:27). James 4:4-8 calls for single-hearted devotion. Hebrews 3:12 warns against an "evil, unbelieving heart."

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your heart is wholly true to the LORD or divided.

Look at what you have accumulated. Does anything have a hold on you?

Thank God that his promise rests on his faithfulness, and not on yours.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God for an undivided heart.
- Ask him to keep you from accumulating what turns you from him.
- Thank him that his promise stands, even when people fail.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 43

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 301 · WEEK 43

Review and Sabbath Rest

Unit 9 review, The Davidic Covenant

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Review and Sabbath

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."
>
> 2 SAMUEL 7:16

REST

Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and Sabbath rest. This is a combined day, so take it slowly. Rest first, then remember.

Begin with the anchor verse of Unit 9, printed above. Read it aloud several times. Say it from memory if you can. This promise holds together everything you have read in the last sixty-seven days: the anointing of David, the covenant with his house, his sin and his repentance, the glory of Solomon's temple, and the sad division at the end. The throne is established forever. That is God's promise, and he does not break his promises.

Notice the sweep of what you have read. A barren woman prays, and a prophet is born. A people ask for a king and get Saul, who fails. God chooses a shepherd boy, who defeats a giant and flees through the wilderness. The throne comes to him, and with it a covenant that outlasts him. He falls, and he is forgiven. His son builds the temple and then loses his heart. The story ends in compromise, but the promise remains.

Read the verse once more, and think of Jesus. Gabriel said to Mary, "The Lord God will give to him the throne of his father David, and he will reign over the house of Jacob forever" (Luke 1:32-33). The promise stands because of him. He is the offspring who is also the Son of God, the king who does not fail.

Then rest. Do not catch up on missed readings. Do not do extra work. Take the Sabbath as a gift, a sign that the work of salvation does not depend on you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This final week of the unit followed the story from the end of David to the beginning of the end of Solomon. You read David's last words, in which he trusted the everlasting covenant, and the account of the census and plague that ended at the temple mount. You saw Solomon anointed, ask for wisdom, and build the temple, and you read his great prayer at its dedication. In the Psalms you read the royal wedding song of Psalm 45 and the prayer for the king in Psalm 72, and the songs of Zion in Psalms 48, 84, and 87, and David's vow of integrity in Psalm 101. You ended with Solomon's fall, and God's decision to tear the kingdom, but for David's sake. The week taught that God's presence is the glory of his people, that his promises stand in spite of human failure, and that we need a greater king.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 9 you have followed the story of the Davidic covenant through 1 and 2 Samuel, 1 Kings 1 to 11, and a large selection of the Psalms. The books of Samuel began with Hannah's song and ended with David's altar. In between, you saw Israel ask for a king and receive Saul, whose partial obedience cost him the throne. You saw God choose David, a shepherd, whom he looked at by the heart and not by the appearance.

You saw David as a fugitive: spared Saul twice, learned to strengthen himself in the LORD, and wrote some of the Bible's greatest prayers in caves and deserts. You saw him become king, take Jerusalem, and bring the ark to the city. And you read the center of the unit, 2 Samuel 7, where God promised David a house, a kingdom, and a throne forever.

You also saw his fall. The affair with Bathsheba and the murder of Uriah were followed by Nathan's confrontation and David's confession. You read Psalms 32 and 51, the great songs of forgiveness. And you saw the consequences: the violence in his house, Absalom's rebellion, and David's weeping flight. God did not abandon the king, and he did not hide the cost of sin.

Solomon's reign was the high point: wisdom, peace, and the temple. But the narrator also showed the quiet compromises that led to his fall. The kingdom would be torn in two, and yet, for David's sake, a lamp would remain in Jerusalem.

The Psalms in this unit were the voice of the king and of the people. Psalm 2 showed the anointed Son. Psalms 3 to 5, 13, 18, 22, 24, 32, 34, 51, and 63 gave words for fear, longing, repentance, and trust. Psalms 45 and 72 pointed to the king whose throne is forever and whose rule reaches to the ends of the earth. The theme throughout was that David's greater Son would come, and that God would keep his word.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What is the covenant God makes with David in 2 Samuel 7?

Recall the promises: a great name, a place for Israel, a son who will build the temple, and a throne established forever. God says he will be a father to the king and discipline him, but his steadfast love will not depart. Notice that David wanted to build God a house, and God said he would build David a house. Write a few sentences about what this covenant promises and why it matters for the rest of the Bible. How does Jesus fulfill it? Look at Luke 1:32-33 and Acts 2:29-36.

How does David's sin with Bathsheba illustrate both grace and consequence?

Look back at 2 Samuel 11 and 12 and Psalms 32 and 51. David's sin was serious, and God sent Nathan to confront him. When David confessed, Nathan said, "The LORD has put away your sin." Yet the child died and the sword did not leave his house. Write about how forgiveness and consequence can both be true. Where do you see this pattern in your own life? How does the cross hold both justice and mercy together?

What makes Solomon's reign both the high point and the beginning of the end?

Think about the wisdom, the peace, the temple, and the prayer of dedication, and then about the horses, the wives, and the high places. The Deuteronomy 17 warnings were ignored one by one. Write a few sentences about how great gifts can lead to great failures. What does Solomon's story teach about the need for an undivided heart? How does Jesus succeed where Solomon failed?

What do the Messianic Psalms teach us about the kind of king God ultimately promises?

Look back at Psalms 2, 22, 45, and 72. The king is God's Son, he suffers and is abandoned, he is addressed as God with an eternal throne, and he defends the poor and rules to the ends of the earth. Write a few sentences describing the king these psalms portray. Which of these features surprises you most? How do they come together in Jesus?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for keeping covenant with David and fulfilling it in Jesus.

Confess where your heart has been divided.

Rest and ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 10 · DAYS 302-333

Wisdom Literature

Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Solomon

How to live in God's world. Wisdom, meaning, and love as covenant life.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding."

PROVERBS 3:5-6

Psalms 19 and 119 beside Proverbs. Psalms 49 and 73 beside Ecclesiastes. Psalm 45 beside the Song of Solomon.

UNIT 10

In this unit

WEEK 44

302	Proverbs 1:1-2:22	*Reading*
303	Proverbs 3:1-4:27	*Reading*
304	Proverbs 5:1-6:35	*Reading*
305	Psalm 19	*Psalm*
306	Psalm 119:1-40	*Psalm*
307	Proverbs 7:1-8:36	*Reading*
308	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 45

309	Proverbs 9:1-11:31	*Reading*
310	Proverbs 12:1-14:35	*Reading*
311	Psalm 119:41-96	*Psalm*
312	Proverbs 15:1-17:28	*Reading*
313	Proverbs 18:1-19:29	*Reading*
314	Proverbs 20:1-21:31	*Reading*
315	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 46

316	Proverbs 22:1-24:34	*Reading*
317	Psalm 119:97-144	*Psalm*
318	Proverbs 25:1-27:27	*Reading*
319	Proverbs 28:1-29:27	*Reading*
320	Proverbs 30:1-31:31	*Reading*
321	Ecclesiastes 1:1-2:26	*Reading*
322	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 47

323	Ecclesiastes 3:1-4:16	*Reading*

324	Psalm 49	*Psalm*
325	Psalm 73	*Psalm*
326	Ecclesiastes 5:1-7:29	*Reading*
327	Ecclesiastes 8:1-10:20	*Reading*
328	Ecclesiastes 11:1-12:14	*Reading*
329	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 48

330	Song of Solomon 1:1-4:16	*Reading*
331	Song of Solomon 5:1-8:14	*Reading*
332	Psalm 45	*Psalm*
333	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 302 · WEEK 44

Proverbs 1:1-2:22

The purpose of Proverbs; wisdom's call; the two paths

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 1:1-2:22. These chapters introduce the whole book. Read the opening statement of purpose slowly, then listen to the voice of Wisdom crying out in the street.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Proverbs is a collection of wise sayings, largely associated with Solomon, gathered over generations in Israel. It is not a book of promises or laws. It is practical instruction on how to live well in God's world, written mostly as a father speaking to his son. The first nine chapters form an extended introduction, urging the reader to choose wisdom over folly. You have just read the story of Solomon, who asked for wisdom and then lost his way. Now you read the wisdom itself.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The book is for "learning about wisdom and instruction, for understanding words of insight" (1:2).
2. "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction" (1:7).
3. "Hear, my son, your father's instruction, and forsake not your mother's teaching" (1:8).
4. Sinners entice: "Come with us... let us ambush the blameless" (1:10-19).
5. "Wisdom cries aloud in the street, in the markets she raises her voice" (1:20).
6. "Whoever listens to me will dwell secure and will be at ease, without dread of disaster" (1:33).

7. “For the LORD gives wisdom; from his mouth come knowledge and understanding” (2:6).

8. Wisdom will deliver “from the way of evil” and “from the forbidden woman” (2:12, 16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening sentence of Proverbs sets the agenda. This is a book about skill in living: how to handle money, words, friendships, work, sex, and anger in a way that fits the world as God made it. The Hebrew word for wisdom means practical skill, like the skill of a craftsman. Wisdom is not first about being clever. It is about being rightly aligned.

Verse 7 is the key to the whole book: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge.” To fear the LORD is to take him seriously as God, to live in reverent awe and trust before him. It is not terror but a right orientation. Everything else in the book flows from it. A person can be intelligent and still be a fool if he leaves God out. The beginning point of wisdom is not information, but a relationship.

The book is delivered as a father’s teaching, and the father warns his son about the pull of the crowd. The sinners’ invitation is attractive: easy money and belonging. But Proverbs says the gang is heading for a trap, “lying in wait for their own blood.” The hardest part of the lesson is that sin often looks like a shortcut.

Wisdom is then personified as a woman crying aloud in the street. She is not hidden. She calls in the markets and at the gates. The tragedy is that people do not listen. When disaster comes, she says, “I will laugh at your calamity,” meaning that those who refused every invitation are left to what they chose. But those who listen “will dwell secure.”

Chapter 2 gives the path to wisdom: receive the words, treasure the commands, call out for insight, and seek it like silver. And it gives the source: “The LORD gives wisdom.” We do not find wisdom by ourselves. We ask for it, and God gives it. The chapter ends with two ways: the path of the upright, who will dwell in the land, and the way of the wicked, who will be cut off.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that Christ became to us “wisdom from God, righteousness and sanctification and redemption” (1 Corinthians 1:30), and that in him “are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge” (Colossians 2:3). James 1:5 invites us to ask God for wisdom. Jesus himself taught in the manner of the wise, with parables and sayings, and said the wise man builds on the rock (Matthew 7:24).

STEP 6

Application

Ask God for wisdom today, as the passage urges. Name one decision where you need it.

Think about the voices that invite you to take a shortcut. Which one is loudest right now?

Treat the fear of the LORD as a starting point and not an extra.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to begin wisdom in you by the fear of him.
- Ask him to keep you from the way of the crowd.
- Tell him where you most need wisdom this week.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 44

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

DAY 303 · WEEK 44

Proverbs 3:1-4:27

Trust the LORD; the value of wisdom; guard your heart

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 3:1-4:27. These chapters contain the unit's anchor, Proverbs 3:5-6. Read it slowly in its setting, and notice how the father urges his son to guard his heart.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The father continues his instruction to his son in a series of short lessons. Chapter 3 gives commands about trust, honor, and discipline, along with promises of life and favor. Chapter 4 recalls the father's own teaching from his father, passing wisdom from generation to generation. These chapters hold some of the best-known verses of the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Let not steadfast love and faithfulness forsake you; bind them around your neck; write them on the tablet of your heart" (3:3).
2. "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding" (3:5).
3. "In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths" (3:6).
4. "Be not wise in your own eyes; fear the LORD, and turn away from evil" (3:7).
5. "Honor the LORD with your wealth and with the firstfruits of all your produce" (3:9).
6. "My son, do not despise the LORD's discipline or be weary of his reproof, for the LORD reproves him whom he loves, as a father the son in whom he delights" (3:11-12).
7. "Blessed is the one who finds wisdom, and the one who gets understanding" (3:13).
8. "Keep your heart with all vigilance, for from it flow the springs of life" (4:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The center of the passage is 3:5-6, a call to total trust. “With all your heart” means with the whole inner person, without holding back. And its opposite is leaning on your own understanding. This is not a call to stop thinking. It is a call to stop treating our own judgment as the final authority. We often feel certain, and we are often wrong. The alternative is to “acknowledge him in all your ways,” to bring God into every decision, large and small. The promise is that “he will make straight your paths.” It does not mean a life without difficulty, but a life that God directs.

The chapter then moves through practical areas. Money: honor the LORD with the firstfruits. Discipline: do not resent it. The father’s note on discipline is among the most important in the book: God reproves those he loves, “as a father the son in whom he delights.” Hardship, correction, and loss are not signs that God has abandoned us. They are signs that we have a Father.

Wisdom is then praised in glowing terms. She is better than silver and gold, more precious than jewels. “Her ways are ways of pleasantness, and all her paths are peace.” She is “a tree of life to those who lay hold of her.” And the writer points to creation: “The LORD by wisdom founded the earth.” The wisdom we are offered is the same wisdom by which the world was made.

Chapter 4 adds the generational dimension and the famous warning to guard the heart. The heart is the source of everything: words, eyes, feet. If the spring is polluted, the stream is polluted. The path of the righteous is “like the light of dawn, which shines brighter and brighter until full day,” while the way of the wicked is like deep darkness.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus trusted the Father completely, even to death, saying, “Not my will, but yours, be done” (Luke 22:42). Hebrews 12:5-11 quotes Proverbs 3:11-12 to teach how God disciplines his children as a Father. John 1:3 and Colossians 1:16 show Christ as the one through whom the world was made, the wisdom of God. Jesus said, “I am the light of the world” (John 8:12), the one who leads us into the full day.

STEP 6

Application

Take Proverbs 3:5-6 with you. Write it somewhere you will see it.

Name one area where you lean on your own understanding. Give it to God.

If you are going through a hard season, ask whether the Father may be correcting you in love.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God where you lean on your own understanding and give it to him.
- Ask him to make your paths straight.
- Thank him that his discipline is love.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 44

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

DAY 304 · WEEK 44

Proverbs 5:1-6:35

Warnings against adultery; practical wisdom

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 5:1-6:35. The father warns his son about adultery and gives a series of practical warnings about debt, laziness, and the things God hates. Read these as pastoral warnings, not just rules.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The father's warnings about sexual temptation are among the most frequent in Proverbs 1 to 9. They reflect the danger to a young man in a world where seductive voices were everywhere. Chapter 6 widens the scope to financial foolishness, laziness, and a list of seven things the LORD hates. The advice is frank, and it assumes that desire is powerful and must be directed.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The lips of a forbidden woman drip honey, and her speech is smoother than oil, but in the end she is bitter as wormwood" (5:3-4).
2. "Keep your way far from her, and do not go near the door of her house" (5:8).
3. "Drink water from your own cistern, flowing water from your own well" (5:15).
4. "Let your fountain be blessed, and rejoice in the wife of your youth" (5:18).
5. "For a man's ways are before the eyes of the LORD, and he ponders all his paths" (5:21).
6. "Go to the ant, O sluggard; consider her ways, and be wise" (6:6).
7. "There are six things that the LORD hates, seven that are an abomination to him" (6:16).
8. "For the commandment is a lamp and the teaching a light, and the reproofs of discipline are the way of life" (6:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first warning is not a prudish one. The father admits that the seductive woman's speech is smooth and sweet. The temptation is real. But "in the end she is bitter as wormwood." The pattern of sin is a sweet start and a bitter end. The wise person looks at the end first.

The practical advice is to keep far away: "Do not go near the door of her house." Wisdom does not test how close it can get. It flees. It is a principle that applies far beyond sexual sin: the way to avoid falling is to avoid the places where one is likely to fall.

The father does not only warn. He points to a positive alternative: delight in the wife of your youth. "Let her breasts fill you at all times with delight; be intoxicated always in her love." The Bible is not suspicious of desire. It places it in marriage, where it is meant to flourish. The metaphor of the cistern and the fountain makes the point: there is a rightful source of satisfaction, and it is close to home. The ultimate reason is theological: "A man's ways are before the eyes of the LORD." Nothing is hidden.

Chapter 6 widens the lens. Be careful about taking on debt for others, and get out quickly if you are in. Look at the ant, which works without anyone forcing her. The sluggard sleeps and poverty comes "like a robber." Then the list of seven things the LORD hates, which includes haughty eyes, a lying tongue, hands that shed innocent blood, and "one who sows discord among brothers."

The chapter returns to adultery with a blunt statement: "He who commits adultery lacks sense; he who does it destroys himself." It describes the cost in plain terms. The commandment is "a lamp" and the teaching "a light," guiding the way through the dark.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus taught that sin begins in the heart and in the eyes (Matthew 5:27-30). Paul says to "flee from sexual immorality" (1 Corinthians 6:18), echoing "keep your way far from her." Hebrews 13:4 says marriage is to be held in honor. Ephesians 5:25-32 shows marriage as a picture of Christ and the church, a love that is faithful. Jesus is the faithful husband who never fails his bride.

STEP 6

Application

Identify one "door" you need to stay far from this week.

If you are married, thank God for your spouse. Do something to delight them.

Consider where laziness or debt are hurting your life, and take one step.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you far from the door of temptation.

Ask him to give you delight in what he has given.

Thank Jesus, the faithful bridegroom.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 44

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

DAY 305 · WEEK 44

Psalm 19

The heavens and the law, creation and word declare God's glory

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 19. It is a psalm in two halves, one about God's glory in the heavens and one about his glory in his word. Notice how the psalmist connects them.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 19 is a psalm of David, and C. S. Lewis called it among the greatest poems in the Psalter. It moves from creation to Scripture to the heart. It stands at a fitting place in this unit: wisdom literature teaches that God's world and God's word fit together. Proverbs says that God made the world by wisdom, and this psalm shows how the world and the law both tell of him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork" (v. 1).
2. "Day to day pours out speech, and night to night reveals knowledge" (v. 2).
3. "There is no speech, nor are there words, whose voice is not heard" (v. 3).
4. "In them he has set a tent for the sun" (v. 4).
5. "The law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul; the testimony of the LORD is sure, making wise the simple" (v. 7).
6. "More to be desired are they than gold, even much fine gold; sweeter also than honey and drippings of the honeycomb" (v. 10).
7. "Who can discern his errors? Declare me innocent from hidden faults" (v. 12).

8 “Let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable in your sight, O LORD, my rock and my redeemer” (v. 14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first half is a hymn to the silent voice of creation. The sky speaks without words, and its message goes out to all the earth. The sun is described as a bridegroom coming out of his chamber, running its course with joy. Creation is a constant witness. It tells us that there is a God, that he is glorious, and that he is powerful. Paul uses this psalm to say that no one is without a witness (Romans 10:18).

But creation’s testimony, however clear, is limited. It tells of God’s glory, but it does not tell us how to know him or be forgiven. So the psalm turns, in verse 7, to the law of the LORD. Six names for God’s word, six descriptions, and six effects fill the second section. The law is perfect, reviving the soul. The testimony is sure, making wise the simple. The precepts are right, rejoicing the heart. The commandment is pure, enlightening the eyes. The fear of the LORD is clean, enduring forever. The rules are true and righteous. God’s word does what the heavens cannot: it restores, it instructs, it gives joy.

The word is also better than wealth and sweeter than honey. The psalmist treasures it. But it also warns: “By them is your servant warned; in keeping them there is great reward.”

The third section is personal. Having seen God’s glory in the heavens and the word, the psalmist sees himself. He realizes that he cannot see his own faults. “Who can discern his errors?” He asks for cleansing from hidden sins and for restraint from presumptuous ones. And the psalm ends with the most beloved prayer: “Let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable in your sight, O LORD, my rock and my redeemer.”

The movement is from creation, to Scripture, to the heart. The glory of God, rightly seen, makes us aware of our need for him.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 1:19-20 and 10:18 draw on this psalm’s picture of creation’s witness. Hebrews 1:1-2 says God has spoken by his Son. John 1:14 shows the Word made flesh, who is the fullest revelation of God’s glory. Jesus said, “The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life” (John 6:63). The “redeemer” of the last verse is fulfilled in Christ (Titus 2:14).

STEP 6

Application

Step outside today and let the sky speak. Thank God for what you see.

Read verses 7 to 9 slowly. Pick the description of God's word that you most need right now.

Pray verse 14 as you start your day.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for speaking through both creation and his word.
- Ask him to cleanse you from hidden faults and keep you from presumption.
- Pray Psalm 19:14 as your own prayer.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 44

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

DAY 306 · WEEK 44

Psalm 119:1-40

Blessed are those whose way is blameless

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 40 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:1-40. This is the first of several readings from the longest chapter in the Bible, a poem in praise of God's word. Notice how many different words for Scripture the psalmist uses.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 119 is an acrostic of twenty-two stanzas, each of eight verses, with each verse in a stanza beginning with the same Hebrew letter. Nearly every verse mentions God's word under one of several names: law, testimonies, precepts, statutes, commandments, rules, word, and promise. The author is unnamed. Over the next weeks you will read it in sections, alongside Proverbs. The first stanzas describe the blessing of walking in God's word and the psalmist's longing to keep it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed are those whose way is blameless, who walk in the law of the LORD!" (v. 1).
2. "With my whole heart I seek you; let me not wander from your commandments!" (v. 10).
3. "How can a young man keep his way pure? By guarding it according to your word" (v. 9).
4. "I have stored up your word in my heart, that I might not sin against you" (v. 11).
5. "Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of your law" (v. 18).
6. "I am a sojourner on the earth; hide not your commandments from me!" (v. 19).
7. "Turn my eyes from looking at worthless things; and give me life in your ways" (v. 37).
8. "I will run in the way of your commandments when you enlarge my heart!" (v. 32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins as Psalm 1 does, with the word “blessed.” The blessed person walks in the law of the LORD. The psalmist is not claiming to have achieved it. His prayer is that he would. He asks God to teach him, to keep him from wandering, and to open his eyes.

Verse 9 asks the question every young person faces: “How can a young man keep his way pure?” The answer is simple and demanding: guard it according to God’s word. The word is not a decoration. It is a guardrail. And verse 11 shows how: “I have stored up your word in my heart.” Memorizing and treasuring Scripture is a defense against sin. The word has to be inside to act as a guard.

Verse 18 is one of the best prayers for anyone who opens a Bible: “Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of your law.” The psalmist knows that reading is not enough. The Spirit must open our eyes. Even a faithful reader needs God’s help to see what is there.

There is an honest strain in these verses. The psalmist feels like a sojourner, a foreigner, in the world. He asks God not to hide his commandments. He feels the pull of what is worthless, so he prays for God to turn his eyes. He knows that obedience does not come naturally.

Verse 32 offers a lovely picture: “I will run in the way of your commandments when you enlarge my heart.” Obedience is not a grim trudge. When God widens the heart, it becomes a run. The psalm is not a manual of rule-keeping. It is the song of someone who has fallen in love with the voice of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the Word made flesh, and he is the one who perfectly walked in the law of the LORD (John 1:14; Matthew 5:17). He said, “Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God” (Matthew 4:4). Ephesians 1:18 prays that “the eyes of your hearts [be] enlightened,” echoing verse 18. Colossians 3:16 urges, “Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly.”

STEP 6

Application

Choose one verse to store up in your heart this week, as verse 11 urges.

Pray verse 18 before you read the Bible tomorrow.

Ask what “worthless things” your eyes are drawn to, and bring that to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you want to seek him with your whole heart.
- Ask him to store his word in your heart so that you do not sin.
- Ask him to open your eyes to wonderful things in it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 44

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

DAY 307 · WEEK 44

Proverbs 7:1-8:36

The seductress; Wisdom personified, the craftsman at God's side

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 63 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 7:1-8:36. Chapter 7 is a vivid warning about a seductive woman, and chapter 8 is one of the great poems of the Bible, in which Wisdom herself speaks. Read chapter 8 slowly. It is the high point of the first nine chapters.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These two chapters set the opposite voices in sharp contrast. In chapter 7, a young man without sense is drawn to a smooth-talking woman. In chapter 8, Wisdom speaks, calling to all who will listen. She reveals that she is older than creation and was with God as he made the world. This is among the passages most important for how the church has understood the relationship between wisdom and Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Bind them on your fingers; write them on the tablet of your heart" (7:3).
2. "And behold, the woman meets him, dressed as a prostitute, wily of heart" (7:10).
3. "All at once he follows her, as an ox goes to the slaughter" (7:22).
4. "Her house is the way to Sheol, going down to the chambers of death" (7:27).
5. "Does not wisdom call? Does not understanding raise her voice?" (8:1).
6. "The fear of the LORD is hatred of evil" (8:13).
7. "The LORD possessed me at the beginning of his work, the first of his acts of old" (8:22).
8. "Then I was beside him, like a master workman, and I was daily his delight, rejoicing before him always" (8:30).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 7 tells the story like a short film. A young man with no sense walks along the street at twilight, near the corner of her house. A woman meets him with flattery, religious language ("I had to offer sacrifices"), and an invitation. He follows "as an ox goes to the slaughter." The chapter describes the way sin deceives: it comes with smooth talk, a good reason, and a sense of safety. And the end is death.

The warning is not simply a moral rule. It is meant to help the reader see what he is walking into. The young man's problem was lack of sense, but also lack of caution. He was in the wrong place at the wrong time. "Do not let your heart turn aside to her ways."

Then Wisdom speaks. She calls from the heights, at the crossroads, and at the gates. Unlike the seductress, she calls openly. She offers "noble things," truth, and righteousness. Her fruit is better than gold. Kings reign by her. And she says, "Those who love me I love, and those who seek me diligently find me."

The center of chapter 8 is verses 22 to 31. Wisdom says that the LORD possessed her at the beginning, before the earth. She was there when he set the heavens in place and marked out the foundations of the earth. "I was beside him, like a master workman." Wisdom is not a mere abstraction. She is portrayed as a person, present with God and delighting in him, and in the human race. Christians have long read this passage in the light of the New Testament as a shadow of Christ, though it should be read carefully. In its own setting, Wisdom is a poetic personification of God's wisdom. In the light of the whole Bible, it points to the Son through whom the world was made.

The chapter ends with a stark choice: "Whoever finds me finds life… but he who fails to find me injures himself; all who hate me love death."

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:1-3 says that the Word was with God in the beginning, and all things were made through him. Colossians 1:15-17 says Christ is "the firstborn of all creation" and that all things were created through him. 1 Corinthians 1:24 calls Christ "the power of God and the wisdom of God." Jesus said, "Come to me, all who labor" (Matthew 11:28), the call of Wisdom in the form of a Savior.

STEP 6

Application

Notice what voices speak to you with smooth words today. Do they lead to life?

Read 8:22-31 aloud as praise to Christ, the one through whom all things were made.

Ask God to help you hate evil, as verse 13 describes.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you from ways that lead to death.

Thank him for Wisdom who calls aloud.

Thank Christ, who was with the Father in the beginning.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 44

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

DAY 308 · WEEK 44

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Proverbs 1:7 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."

PROVERBS 1:7

REST

Meditation

This verse is the motto of the whole book of Proverbs, and it appears again in 9:10. Everything in the book rests on it.

"The fear of the LORD." The word fear has two layers in the Bible. There is the awe that shakes us when we realize who God is, and there is the trust that keeps us coming to him. A child who loves and respects his father fears him in this sense: he takes him seriously and does not want to displease him. To fear the LORD is to live as though God is real, holy, good, and in charge.

"Is the beginning." The word can mean either the first part or the chief part. Both are true. It is where wisdom starts, and it is what wisdom is made of. You cannot skip it and arrive at wisdom some other way.

“Of knowledge.” It is the starting point for knowing anything rightly. The world makes sense only if the one who made it is acknowledged. Apart from him, knowledge becomes fragmented, proud, or useless.

“Fools despise wisdom and instruction.” The fool is not one who lacks intelligence but one who rejects correction. He thinks he knows best. The contrast is between a person who bows to God and a person who bows to himself.

For the Christian, the fear of the LORD is not opposed to the love of God. It deepens as we see his holiness and his grace together at the cross. We fear him because he is holy, and we run to him because he is merciful. Pray this verse often, and ask God to give you a heart that fears him.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the wisdom books. You opened Proverbs and heard the father’s call to his son, with the fear of the LORD as the starting point. You read the anchor of the unit, Proverbs 3:5-6, which calls us to trust the LORD with all our heart and not to lean on our own understanding. You read the warnings about adultery, debt, and laziness, and the beautiful alternative of faithful love. In the Psalms you saw the glory of God in creation and in his word in Psalm 19, and began Psalm 119 with its longing to walk in God’s law. You ended the week with Wisdom’s own speech in Proverbs 8, where she stands beside God at creation. The week taught that wisdom starts with reverent trust in God, that his word guards the heart, and that Christ is the wisdom of God.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Proverbs 3:5-6 asks us to trust the LORD with all our heart and not lean on our own understanding. Where are you leaning on your own understanding right now?

Proverbs 8 pictures Wisdom as present with God at creation, and the New Testament shows Christ as the wisdom of God. How does that change the way you think about seeking wisdom?

Psalm 119:11 says, “I have stored up your word in my heart, that I might not sin against you.” What is one practical way you can store up God’s word this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to begin knowing him with fear.

Thank him for Christ, the wisdom of God.

Rest, and ask him to guard your way with his word.

DAY 309 · WEEK 45

Proverbs 9:1-11:31

Wisdom and Folly's rival invitations

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 9:1-11:31. Chapter 9 closes the first major section with two rival invitations. Chapters 10 and 11 begin the collection of short sayings. Notice the change of style.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 9 ends the long introduction with a banquet scene. Lady Wisdom and the woman Folly both call out from the heights of the city, but one leads to life and the other to the grave. Then, beginning at chapter 10, the book changes. The long speeches give way to short two-line sayings, mostly about the contrast between the righteous and the wicked. These are the proverbs most people think of.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Wisdom has built her house; she has hewn her seven pillars" (9:1).
2. "Leave your simple ways, and live, and walk in the way of insight" (9:6).
3. "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom, and the knowledge of the Holy One is insight" (9:10).
4. "The woman Folly is loud; she is seductive and knows nothing" (9:13).
5. "But he does not know that the dead are there, that her guests are in the depths of Sheol" (9:18).
6. "A wise son makes a glad father, but a foolish son is a sorrow to his mother" (10:1).
7. "When pride comes, then comes disgrace, but with the humble is wisdom" (11:2).

8 “Whoever brings blessing will be enriched, and one who waters will himself be watered” (11:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The picture in chapter 9 is of two banquets. Wisdom has built her house, prepared her meat, mixed her wine, and sent out her servants. The invitation is open to the simple. Folly also sits at the door of her house, on the high places of the city, calling to those passing by. The words are similar, but the end is different. “He does not know that the dead are there.” The meal that looks like life is the doorway to death.

The chapter’s lesson is that no one is neutral. Everyone is eating at one of the two tables. We are being formed either by wisdom or by folly. And verse 10 repeats the theme: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom.”

Chapter 10 begins the first collection of sayings attributed to Solomon. They are scattered, not organized by topic, and the reader is meant to take them one at a time, like a string of pearls. Many are contrasts: the righteous and the wicked, the diligent and the lazy, the wise and the fool.

It is important to read proverbs as proverbs. They are general truths about how the world tends to work, not promises that apply in every case. “The hand of the diligent will rule” is generally true. It is not a guarantee. Proverbs describe the grain of the world, the way things usually go when God’s moral order is at work. The book of Job and Ecclesiastes will later explore the exceptions.

Several themes emerge in these chapters: honest speech, generosity, humility, and the danger of pride. “Whoever is generous will be blessed.” “One gives freely, yet grows all the richer.” Generosity is not a loss but a form of wisdom. The righteous are described as a tree of life, a “fruit” that helps others. And “whoever trusts in his riches will fall, but the righteous will flourish like a green leaf.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told parables of two houses (Matthew 7:24-27) and two banquets (Luke 14:15-24), and spoke of the narrow and wide gates (Matthew 7:13-14). He is the true wisdom who sends out his servants with the invitation to come to the feast (Matthew 22:1-10). He said, “It is more blessed to give than to receive” (Acts 20:35), echoing 11:25. Proverbs 11:30 (“the fruit of the righteous is a tree of life”) points to Revelation 22:2.

STEP 6

Application

Ask which table you are eating at today. What is feeding you: wisdom or folly?

Practice one act of generosity this week and watch what it does to your heart.

Read proverbs one at a time, and slowly. Choose one to think about throughout the day.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Accept Wisdom's invitation, and tell God what that means for you.
- Ask him to keep you from the table of Folly.
- Thank Christ for spreading a feast for you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 45

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path."

PSALM 119:105

DAY 310 · WEEK 45

Proverbs 12:1-14:35

The fruit of the lips; diligence; the way of the upright

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 12:1-14:35. These chapters continue the collection of contrasting sayings. As you read, look for what the proverbs say about the tongue, hard work, and the way that seems right.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters continue the first Solomonic collection. The sayings are brief, and they move quickly from subject to subject. They are not meant to be read all at once but to be pondered. Look for repeated themes: speech, work, the fear of the LORD, and the difference between appearance and reality. Some of the most quoted proverbs appear here.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Whoever loves discipline loves knowledge, but he who hates reproof is stupid” (12:1).
2. “There is one whose rash words are like sword thrusts, but the tongue of the wise brings healing” (12:18).
3. “Anxiety in a man’s heart weighs him down, but a good word makes him glad” (12:25).
4. “The soul of the sluggard craves and gets nothing, while the soul of the diligent is richly supplied” (13:4).
5. “Whoever walks with the wise becomes wise, but the companion of fools will suffer harm” (13:20).
6. “Whoever spares the rod hates his son, but he who loves him is diligent to discipline him” (13:24).
7. “There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way to death” (14:12).

8 “Righteousness exalts a nation, but sin is a reproach to any people” (14:34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sayings of these chapters circle around a few basic truths. First, the willingness to be corrected is the mark of the wise. “Whoever loves discipline loves knowledge.” The person who hates correction is called “stupid,” a strong word. It is a challenge to anyone who is touchy about criticism. Growth requires being willing to be told when we are wrong.

Second, words matter. Rash words are like swords, but wise words heal. The tongue can wound or it can restore. “A good word makes him glad.” A kind word to an anxious person is a gift. The book returns again and again to speech, because speech reveals and shapes the heart.

Third, the company we keep forms us. “Whoever walks with the wise becomes wise.” We become like those we spend time with. The proverb is a reminder to choose friendships carefully, and to be the kind of friend others can learn from.

The most searching proverb in the section is 14:12: “There is a way that seems right to a man, but its end is the way to death.” It appears twice in the book (16:25). The danger is not only that we choose obvious wrong. It is that we are often convinced we are right. Self-deception is a serious problem, and it is why we need God’s word and wise counsel. We cannot trust our own sense of rightness.

The collection also includes strong statements on work, honesty, and the poor. “Whoever oppresses a poor man insults his Maker, but he who is generous to the needy honors him.” How we treat the poor is a statement about how we regard God. And there are sayings about the fear of the LORD as a fountain of life and a place of confidence.

The section ends with a corporate lesson: “Righteousness exalts a nation.” Moral character is not a private matter. It shapes whole societies.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said that out of the abundance of the heart the mouth speaks (Matthew 12:34), and that we will give an account for every careless word (Matthew 12:36). He warned that many call the narrow way hard and choose the broad one (Matthew 7:13-14). Proverbs 14:31 is echoed in Matthew 25:40: “As you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me.” James 3 expands on the power of the tongue.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a recent conversation. Did your words wound or heal? Ask forgiveness if needed.

Examine your friendships. Who are you becoming like?

Ask God where you might have a “way that seems right” that leads somewhere else.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you a love for correction.
- Ask him to make your words bring healing.
- Ask him to show you the way that seems right but is not.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 45

“Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path.”

PSALM 119:105

DAY 311 · WEEK 45

Psalm 119:41-96

Steadfast love and the commandments

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:41-96. Today's section moves from steadfast love to affliction. Notice how the psalmist finds comfort in God's word in suffering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second reading from Psalm 119, covering stanzas four through eleven. The psalmist is under pressure. Insolent people mock him, and he suffers affliction. Yet again and again, he turns to the word of God, which he finds to be his comfort, his song, and his life. The section includes some of the most famous lines of the whole psalm.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Let your steadfast love come to me, O LORD, your salvation according to your promise" (v. 41).
2. "And I shall walk in a wide place, for I have sought your precepts" (v. 45).
3. "This is my comfort in my affliction, that your promise gives me life" (v. 50).
4. "Your statutes have been my songs in the house of my sojourning" (v. 54).
5. "The LORD is my portion; I promise to keep your words" (v. 57).
6. "It is good for me that I was afflicted, that I might learn your statutes" (v. 71).
7. "Forever, O LORD, your word is firmly fixed in the heavens" (v. 89).
8. "If your law had not been my delight, I would have perished in my affliction" (v. 92).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Verse 41 begins with a request for God's steadfast love. The psalmist asks that God's covenant love come to him, according to his promise. The word of God and the love of God are tied together. The promise is the way God's love reaches us.

The theme of affliction threads through the section. The psalmist does not say that God's word makes life painless. He says that it is his comfort in affliction. "Your promise gives me life." The promise is what keeps him alive when everything else is hard. A believer in difficult times needs something to hold, and God's word is it. The psalmist even makes songs from the statutes "in the house of my sojourning." He sings the word in a foreign place.

The most challenging line is verse 71: "It is good for me that I was afflicted, that I might learn your statutes." It is a statement made in hindsight. The writer does not say that suffering is pleasant. He says that it taught him. Affliction drove him to God's word and made him learn what comfort cannot. And verse 67: "Before I was afflicted I went astray, but now I keep your word." Trouble corrected him.

The psalm also says the LORD is his portion, as the Levites had no land but God himself as their inheritance. For the psalmist, owning God is greater than owning anything else.

Verse 89 stands as a statement of confidence: "Forever, O LORD, your word is firmly fixed in the heavens." Human opinions shift. Cultures change. God's word does not. His faithfulness continues to all generations, and the earth established by him endures. And verse 92 is a stark acknowledgment: "If your law had not been my delight, I would have perished."

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, "Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away" (Matthew 24:35). Romans 8:28 says God works all things for good for those who love him, echoing verse 71. Hebrews 12:11 speaks of the peaceful fruit of discipline. 2 Corinthians 1:3-5 describes God as the Father of mercies and God of all comfort. Peter writes that the word of the Lord remains forever (1 Peter 1:25).

STEP 6

Application

If you are in affliction, name one promise from Scripture to hold on to this week.

Look back at a hardship and ask what God taught you through it.

Sing or read aloud a verse of Scripture in a hard place, as the psalmist did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask for God's steadfast love according to his promise.
- Tell him where his promise gives you life in affliction.
- Ask him to fix his word in your heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 45

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path."

PSALM 119:105

DAY 312 · WEEK 45

Proverbs 15:1-17:28

The gentle answer; God weighs the heart; friendship

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 15:1-17:28. As you read, look for what these chapters teach about words, the heart, and the sovereignty of God over human plans.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters continue the Solomonic collection, and now more sayings speak directly about the LORD. They deal with the gentle answer, the way God sees the heart, plans and God's purposes, pride, and friendship. Chapter 16 in particular grapples with how human planning and divine control fit together.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "A soft answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger" (15:1).
2. "The eyes of the LORD are in every place, keeping watch on the evil and the good" (15:3).
3. "Without counsel plans fail, but with many advisers they succeed" (15:22).
4. "All the ways of a man are pure in his own eyes, but the LORD weighs the spirit" (16:2).
5. "Commit your work to the LORD, and your plans will be established" (16:3).
6. "The heart of man plans his way, but the LORD establishes his steps" (16:9).
7. "Pride goes before destruction, and a haughty spirit before a fall" (16:18).
8. "A friend loves at all times, and a brother is born for adversity" (17:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The famous opening line of chapter 15 gives a practical truth: “A soft answer turns away wrath.” A gentle word can defuse a conflict. The next lines contrast the wise tongue with the foolish mouth, and show that the way we speak reflects the state of our hearts. The whole section turns often to the tongue: “A gentle tongue is a tree of life, but perverseness in it breaks the spirit.”

Verse 3 says that “the eyes of the LORD are in every place.” It can be a comfort or a warning. For the one who hides, it is a warning. For the one who walks in integrity, it is a comfort. God sees. We are not unobserved, and we are not forgotten.

Chapter 16 sets a key principle of Christian life: our planning and God’s sovereignty. “The heart of man plans his way, but the LORD establishes his steps.” We should make plans. The Bible does not say planning is wrong. But we hold them with open hands. God has the final say. “The lot is cast into the lap, but its every decision is from the LORD.” Even what looks like chance is under his rule. This does not make us passive. It makes us humble and trusting. “Commit your work to the LORD, and your plans will be established.”

Verse 2 is a warning about self-assessment: “All the ways of a man are pure in his own eyes, but the LORD weighs the spirit.” We tend to judge ourselves by our intentions and others by their actions. God weighs the heart. And the famous verse 18 warns about pride, “before a fall.” The humble in spirit, by contrast, are described as better off than the proud.

Chapter 17 includes a series of sayings about friendship and family: “A friend loves at all times.” “A joyful heart is good medicine, but a crushed spirit dries up the bones.” And it also warns about quarreling. “The beginning of strife is like letting out water, so quit before the quarrel breaks out.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus, “when he was reviled, did not revile in return” (1 Peter 2:23), and taught that blessed are the meek (Matthew 5:5). Paul wrote, “Let your speech always be gracious” (Colossians 4:6). James 4:13-15 echoes Proverbs 16:9: “You ought to say, If the Lord wills, we will live.” Jesus, the friend of sinners (Luke 7:34), is “a friend who sticks closer than a brother.” Romans 8:28 holds God’s sovereignty and our good together.

STEP 6

Application

In your next tense conversation, try a soft answer.

Hold one of your plans loosely today. Commit it to the LORD, and notice what changes.

Consider where you judge yourself by your intentions, and ask God to weigh your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you gentle answers.
- Ask him to establish your steps and keep you from pride.
- Thank him that he weighs the spirit with perfect knowledge.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 45

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path."

PSALM 119:105

DAY 313 · WEEK 45

Proverbs 18:1-19:29

The tongue; pride; plans and the LORD's purposes

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 18:1-19:29. Notice the sayings about the power of the tongue, the LORD as a refuge, and how God's purposes stand above human plans.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapters 18 and 19 continue to gather sayings on speech, friendship, wealth and poverty, and discipline. Some of the best loved lines in the book are here, including the strong tower and the friend who sticks closer than a brother. The sayings are loosely organized but return to central themes of the book.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "If one gives an answer before he hears, it is his folly and shame" (18:13).
2. "The name of the LORD is a strong tower; the righteous man runs into it and is safe" (18:10).
3. "The rich man's wealth is his strong city, and like a high wall in his imagination" (18:11).
4. "Death and life are in the power of the tongue, and those who love it will eat its fruits" (18:21).
5. "He who finds a wife finds a good thing and obtains favor from the LORD" (18:22).
6. "A man of many companions may come to ruin, but there is a friend who sticks closer than a brother" (18:24).
7. "Whoever is generous to the poor lends to the LORD, and he will repay him for his deed" (19:17).

8 “Many are the plans in the mind of a man, but it is the purpose of the LORD that will stand” (19:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Two strongholds are set side by side in chapter 18. The name of the LORD is a strong tower, and the rich man’s wealth is a strong city “in his imagination.” The comparison is sharp. The rich man imagines himself secure, but his wall is only in his mind. The righteous man runs to the LORD and is actually safe. We all have something we run to when life is threatening: money, a plan, a person, a reputation. Proverbs asks whether that thing is a real tower or an imagined one.

The proverbs on speech continue. “If one gives an answer before he hears, it is his folly.” Listening before speaking is a mark of wisdom. “Death and life are in the power of the tongue.” The tongue is a powerful instrument. The one who uses it will taste the results, good or bad.

A significant saying about friendship appears at the end of chapter 18. “A man of many companions may come to ruin, but there is a friend who sticks closer than a brother.” Quantity is not the measure of friendship. A single faithful friend is worth more than a crowd. Believers have always seen in this verse a picture of Christ.

Chapter 19 contains a strong statement on caring for the poor: “Whoever is generous to the poor lends to the LORD, and he will repay him.” Generosity to the poor is loaning to God himself. He takes it personally. It is one of the Bible’s most striking ideas: the poor man is God’s debtor, and God promises to repay.

The key theological statement of the chapter is verse 21: “Many are the plans in the mind of a man, but it is the purpose of the LORD that will stand.” We make many plans. Some come to nothing. But God’s purpose cannot be overturned. This is a comfort to those who trust him, and a warning to those who plot against him. And verse 23: “The fear of the LORD leads to life, and whoever has it rests satisfied.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the friend who sticks closer than a brother. He said, “No longer do I call you servants… but I have called you friends” (John 15:15). He is the strong tower, the refuge of the weary (Hebrews 6:18). Matthew 25:40 shows that kindness to the least is kindness to Christ. In Acts 4:28 the plans of men against Jesus served only “whatever your hand and your plan had predestined to take place.”

STEP 6

Application

Name your “strong tower.” Is it the LORD, or something imaginary?

Practice listening fully before answering in your next important conversation.

Give something to a person in need this week, and think of it as lending to the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Run into the strong tower of God’s name, and tell him why you need it.
- Ask him to guard your tongue and teach you to listen.
- Thank Jesus, the friend who sticks closer than a brother.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 45

“Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path.”

PSALM 119:105

DAY 314 · WEEK 45

Proverbs 20:1-21:31

Justice, integrity, and the king's heart in the LORD's hand

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 20:1-21:31. These chapters continue the collection. Notice what is said about the king, justice, and the heart, and the great statement in 21:1 and 21:31.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The sayings of chapters 20 and 21 have a strong focus on rulers, justice, and honest dealing. This is fitting for a collection associated with a king. They also continue the theme of God's rule over human hearts and plans. As the last of the Solomonic sayings before the "Sayings of the Wise," these chapters are a high point in the theology of providence.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Wine is a mocker, strong drink a brawler, and whoever is led astray by it is not wise" (20:1).
2. "Who can say, I have made my heart pure; I am clean from my sin?" (20:9).
3. "The hearing ear and the seeing eye, the LORD has made them both" (20:12).
4. "Do not say, I will repay evil; wait for the LORD, and he will deliver you" (20:22).
5. "The king's heart is a stream of water in the hand of the LORD; he turns it wherever he will" (21:1).
6. "Every way of a man is right in his own eyes, but the LORD weighs the heart" (21:2).
7. "To do righteousness and justice is more acceptable to the LORD than sacrifice" (21:3).
8. "The horse is made ready for the day of battle, but the victory belongs to the LORD" (21:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 20 begins with a warning about drink, then turns to honesty and the king's role. A king who sits on the throne of judgment "winnows all evil with his eyes." Good rule requires moral discernment. Yet the chapter also contains a question that humbles every ruler: "Who can say, I have made my heart pure; I am clean from my sin?" The answer is no one. Even the wisest king, and even the wisest reader, needs forgiveness.

Verse 22 is a gem for those who are wronged: "Do not say, I will repay evil; wait for the LORD, and he will deliver you." It echoes the principle of David's restraint with Saul. Vengeance belongs to God. Waiting is an act of faith. Honest scales and weights also come up repeatedly. "Unequal weights and unequal measures are both alike an abomination to the LORD." The God of the temple cares about the marketplace.

Chapter 21 opens with one of the most sweeping statements of God's sovereignty. "The king's heart is a stream of water in the hand of the LORD; he turns it wherever he will." The most powerful person in the land has a heart that is directed by God, as a farmer directs the channel of irrigation. God is not threatened by kings. He guides them, even when they do not know it. This is comfort for those living under unjust or foolish rulers.

Verse 3 repeats what Samuel told Saul and the prophets will say: "To do righteousness and justice is more acceptable to the LORD than sacrifice." Ritual without righteousness is empty. And verse 13 states a principle of mercy: "Whoever closes his ear to the cry of the poor will himself call out and not be answered."

The chapter ends with a verse that sums up providence: "The horse is made ready for the day of battle, but the victory belongs to the LORD." Prepare, plan, and work, but know that the result is God's. The following verse, 21:30, says, "No wisdom, no understanding, no counsel can avail against the LORD."

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that governing authorities are instituted by God (Romans 13:1), and 1 Timothy 2:1-2 urges prayer for kings. Jesus said, "My Father is working until now, and I am working" (John 5:17). Romans 12:19 echoes verse 22: "Never avenge yourselves... leave it to the wrath of God." Jesus quoted the prophets that God desires "mercy, and not sacrifice" (Matthew 9:13). Psalm 33:16-17 adds that a war horse is a false hope for victory.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for a leader whose decisions affect you, trusting that God can turn their heart.

When you are wronged, practice waiting on the LORD instead of repaying.

Do your part in a hard task, and release the outcome to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Admit before God that you cannot make your own heart pure.
- Ask him for mercy and for patience when you are wronged.
- Thank him that he holds even the king's heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 45

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path."

PSALM 119:105

DAY 315 · WEEK 45

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 119:105 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path."

PSALM 119:105

REST

Meditation

This is one of the best-loved verses about Scripture, from the middle of the longest chapter in the Bible. It uses a simple image: a lamp.

"Your word." The psalmist speaks to God, and says that the word is his. It is not the opinion of men. It is God's speech, and it has his authority and his love in it.

"Is a lamp to my feet." In the ancient world, a lamp was a small oil flame, held at the level of the feet. It did not light up the whole road. It showed the next few steps. This is how God's word usually works. We do not get a complete map of our future. We get enough light for the next step. And the psalmist does not complain about it. He is grateful for it. We walk by faith, one step at a time.

"And a light to my path." The path is the whole road of life, and the word shows where it leads. "Path" also suggests direction. The word of God not only lights each step but also reveals where it all goes, and warns of where the other paths end.

The verse invites us to treat the Bible not as a book of general ideas but as a daily guide. When you are unsure of a decision, the lamp is for your feet. When you are tempted, the lamp shows the pit. When you are afraid of the future, the lamp reminds you that the one who holds it knows the way.

For the Christian, this verse is fulfilled in Christ, who said, “I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life” (John 8:12). The word that lights our path has a name. Walk in his light.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you worked through the heart of Proverbs. You read the two banquets of Wisdom and Folly, and the first collection of Solomon’s sayings, with their contrasts between the righteous and the wicked. You saw how the gentle answer turns away wrath, how the tongue holds the power of life and death, and how the name of the LORD is a strong tower. You saw that human plans are held in God’s hand: the heart of man plans his way, but the LORD establishes his steps, and the king’s heart is a stream of water in his hand. In Psalm 119 you heard the psalmist turn to God’s word in affliction and say that it is good that he was afflicted. The week taught that wisdom is practical, that God is sovereign over human plans, and that his word is a light for each step.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Proverbs says that the name of the LORD is a strong tower, and that a rich man’s wealth is a strong city only in his imagination. What do you run to when you feel unsafe, and is it a real tower?

Jesus is the friend who sticks closer than a brother, and the one who held fast to the Father’s will. How does knowing his friendship change how you face a lonely or hard moment this week?

Psalm 119:105 says God’s word is a lamp to the feet. What is the next step you need light for, and how will you ask God for it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his word is a lamp for your feet.

Thank him for the strong tower of his name.

Rest, and ask him to establish your steps.

DAY 316 · WEEK 46

Proverbs 22:1-24:34

Sayings of the wise; warnings about wealth

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 68 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 22:1-24:34. A new section begins, the Sayings of the Wise. Read for what it says about reputation, wealth, and what to do when you fail.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

At 22:17 the collection changes. The father's voice returns, and the sayings are introduced as "the words of the wise." Many scholars see a link with ancient Egyptian wisdom texts, which shows that Israel's sages worked within the wider world of wisdom while rooting it in the fear of the LORD. These chapters give practical teaching on money, work, justice, and enemies.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "A good name is to be chosen rather than great riches, and favor is better than silver or gold" (22:1).
2. "The rich and the poor meet together; the LORD is the Maker of them all" (22:2).
3. "Train up a child in the way he should go; even when he is old he will not depart from it" (22:6).
4. "The rich rules over the poor, and the borrower is the slave of the lender" (22:7).
5. "Do not toil to acquire wealth; be discerning enough to desist" (23:4).
6. "Rescue those who are being taken away to death" (24:11).
7. "For the righteous falls seven times and rises again, but the wicked stumble in times of calamity" (24:16).

8 “Do not rejoice when your enemy falls, and let not your heart be glad when he stumbles” (24:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 22 opens with values. A good name, meaning a reputation for integrity, is worth more than wealth. And the rich and poor share the same Maker. No class is beyond God’s concern. The saying prepares for warnings elsewhere against exploiting the poor, “for the LORD will plead their cause.”

The well-known verse about training a child is a proverb, not a promise. It describes the general way that early formation shapes a life. It calls parents to teach deliberately, and it does not guarantee a result in every case. Proverbs elsewhere acknowledges that children can choose a different path. What the verse affirms is the power and the responsibility of early instruction.

Chapter 23 contains warnings about gluttony, drunkenness, and the pursuit of wealth. “Do not toil to acquire wealth.” Wealth is fragile: “When your eyes light on it, it is gone, for suddenly it sprouts wings.” The sayings on alcohol are vivid, describing its effects with humor and horror. The father also gives a tender instruction: “My son, give me your heart, and let your eyes observe my ways.” Wisdom is not just information but a relationship of trust.

Chapter 24 includes two of the book’s most challenging lines. Verse 11 calls us to rescue those being led to death. We cannot say, “Behold, we did not know this,” for God weighs the heart. Silence in the face of injustice is a failure. And verse 16 gives a glimpse of resilience: “The righteous falls seven times and rises again.” The righteous person is not one who never falls, but one who gets up. This gives comfort to anyone who has failed.

The warning about enemies is also bracing: “Do not rejoice when your enemy falls.” The reason is that the LORD will see it and be displeased. Gloating is a sin. And the chapter closes with a picture of the sluggard’s field, overgrown with thorns, and a warning that poverty comes “like a robber.” The wise man looks at the field and “receives instruction.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Let the children come to me” (Mark 10:14), and called for justice and mercy toward the least. Paul instructs fathers to bring children up “in the discipline and instruction of the Lord” (Ephesians 6:4). Jesus told the story of the Good Samaritan, who rescued the one being left for dead (Luke 10:30-37). The righteous who falls and rises again points to the One who rose, and to the grace that lifts his people (Micah 7:8).

STEP 6

Application

Ask what your reputation says about you, and whether it reflects your character.

Think about someone you could “rescue” this week: someone who needs an advocate.

If you have failed recently, hold on to 24:16. Get up.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you a good name before him.
- Ask him to help you rescue those being led toward death.
- Ask him to keep you from gloating over an enemy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 46

“Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised.”

PROVERBS 31:30

DAY 317 · WEEK 46

Psalm 119:97-144

The commandments as wisdom

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:97-144. This section is the heart of the psalm. Notice how the psalmist describes the sweetness, the light, and the righteousness of God's word.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the third reading from Psalm 119, covering stanzas thirteen through eighteen. It contains the famous verse 105, the lamp, and some of the strongest statements about how God's word gives wisdom. It fits the theme of the unit: the commandments as a source of insight and a guide for life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh how I love your law! It is my meditation all the day" (v. 97).
2. "Your commandment makes me wiser than my enemies, for it is ever with me" (v. 98).
3. "I have more understanding than all my teachers, for your testimonies are my meditation" (v. 99).
4. "How sweet are your words to my taste, sweeter than honey to my mouth!" (v. 103).
5. "Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path" (v. 105).
6. "The unfolding of your words gives light; it imparts understanding to the simple" (v. 130).
7. "My eyes shed streams of tears, because people do not keep your law" (v. 136).
8. "Your testimonies are righteous forever; give me understanding that I may live" (v. 144).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The stanza that begins at verse 97 starts with an exclamation: “Oh how I love your law!” The psalmist does not just obey. He loves. His meditation is constant, “all the day.” This is the Bible’s picture of a believer who treasures God’s word as a delight and a source of wisdom.

The claims of verses 98 to 100 are striking. The psalmist says he is wiser than his enemies, his teachers, and the aged. This is not arrogance but a statement about the power of the word. A humble student of Scripture may have more insight than a clever person who ignores it. Wisdom is not a matter of age or education. It is a matter of heeding God’s testimonies.

Verse 103 describes the word as sweet: “sweeter than honey.” It is both nourishing and delightful. And verse 105 gives the great image of the lamp. Verse 130 adds that “the unfolding of your words gives light.” The word brings understanding, especially to the simple. You do not need to be an expert. The unfolding, the opening up, of the word gives light.

The psalm is not naive. The section includes pain. In verse 136, the psalmist’s eyes shed streams of tears because others do not keep the law. Love for God’s word includes grief at its neglect. And in verses 107 and 139, he describes his affliction and his zeal consuming him. This is a person who feels deeply.

Verse 144 closes the passage with a request that sums up what the psalm is about: “Give me understanding that I may live.” Understanding and life belong together. To know God’s word is to live. The psalmist’s prayer is the same as ours: help me to see.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Man shall not live by bread alone” (Matthew 4:4), and “The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life” (John 6:63). He grieved over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41), echoing verse 136. Revelation 10:9-10 uses the image of the word as sweet as honey. Paul writes that the Scriptures “are able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus” (2 Timothy 3:15).

STEP 6

Application

Read a short passage of Scripture today and ask: what is sweet in this?

Pray that you would grieve what grieves God.

Ask for understanding not just to know but to live.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you love about his law.
- Ask him for understanding that gives light.
- Grieve with him over those who do not keep his law.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 46

"Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised."

PROVERBS 31:30

DAY 318 · WEEK 46

Proverbs 25:1-27:27

Hezekiah's collection; friendship; self-knowledge

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 25:1-27:27. A new collection begins, copied by the men of Hezekiah. As you read, notice the images from nature and everyday life, and what the sayings say about friends and enemies.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Proverbs 25:1 says that these are "also proverbs of Solomon which the men of Hezekiah king of Judah copied." They come from the time of Hezekiah, about 700 BC, when the scribes of Judah collected and preserved earlier wisdom. This collection is rich in similes and comparisons, drawn from the world of ordinary experience: snow, rain, apples, thorn bushes, iron.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It is the glory of God to conceal things, but the glory of kings is to search things out" (25:2).
2. "A word fitly spoken is like apples of gold in a setting of silver" (25:11).
3. "If your enemy is hungry, give him bread to eat, and if he is thirsty, give him water to drink" (25:21).
4. "Like a dog that returns to his vomit is a fool who repeats his folly" (26:11).
5. "Do not answer a fool according to his folly, lest you be like him yourself" (26:4), and "Answer a fool according to his folly, lest he be wise in his own eyes" (26:5).
6. "Do not boast about tomorrow, for you do not know what a day may bring" (27:1).
7. "Faithful are the wounds of a friend; profuse are the kisses of an enemy" (27:6).

8 “Iron sharpens iron, and one man sharpens another” (27:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The collection begins with a reflection on knowledge: “It is the glory of God to conceal things, but the glory of kings is to search things out.” God has left much to be discovered. The search for understanding is a kind of honor, and wisdom requires humility before the mystery of God.

The collection is full of word pictures. A word fitly spoken is like gold apples in a silver setting: beautiful, fitting, valuable. A faithful messenger is like cold snow in harvest time. A man without self-control is “like a city broken into and left without walls.” These images ask the reader to slow down and to see the world as a source of wisdom.

Chapter 25’s counsel about enemies is among the most radical in the Old Testament: “If your enemy is hungry, give him bread to eat.” Paul quotes it in Romans 12:20. To give food to an enemy is to overcome evil with good. The “burning coals” are probably a picture of shame leading to repentance.

Chapter 26 gathers the proverbs on fools in a stunning series. The seeming contradiction between 26:4 and 26:5 is intentional. Sometimes a fool should not be answered, so that you do not become like him. Sometimes he should be answered, so that he does not think himself wise. Wisdom is knowing which. Proverbs are not formulas. They require discernment.

Chapter 27 turns to friendship and self-knowledge. “Faithful are the wounds of a friend.” A true friend tells the truth, even when it hurts. “Iron sharpens iron.” We grow through honest relationships. And “as in water face reflects face, so the heart of man reflects the man.” The state of our heart shows in our life. The chapter ends with the call to know the condition of your flocks, a reminder that wealth does not last forever and that careful stewardship matters.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Proverbs 25:21-22 in Romans 12:20 and says, “Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good.” Jesus said, “Love your enemies” (Matthew 5:44), and showed it on the cross. James 4:13-14 echoes 27:1. Hebrews 10:24 calls believers to “stir up one another to love and good works.” Peter uses 26:11 in 2 Peter 2:22.

STEP 6

Application

Do something kind this week for someone who has been unkind to you.

Ask a trusted friend for honest feedback, and be ready to hear it as a wound that heals.

Think of a “word fitly spoken” that you could offer to someone today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to make you humble in your search for understanding.

Ask him to teach you to speak a word fitly spoken.

Ask him for the grace to receive the wounds of a friend.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 46

“Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised.”

PROVERBS 31:30

DAY 319 · WEEK 46

Proverbs 28:1-29:27

Justice, leadership, and the righteous

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 55 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 28:1-29:27. These chapters are about leadership, justice, and the effect of rulers on a nation. Notice what they say about confession, and the fear of man.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters continue the collection copied by Hezekiah's men. The focus turns to rulers and the righteous. They reflect the concern for justice that runs through the prophets. The wise sayings here are strongly moral and contrast the righteous with the wicked, the oppressor with the generous, and the stubborn with the repentant.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The wicked flee when no one pursues, but the righteous are bold as a lion" (28:1).
2. "Whoever conceals his transgressions will not prosper, but he who confesses and forsakes them will obtain mercy" (28:13).
3. "Blessed is the one who fears the LORD always, but whoever hardens his heart will fall into calamity" (28:14).
4. "Whoever trusts in his own mind is a fool, but he who walks in wisdom will be delivered" (28:26).
5. "Whoever gives to the poor will not want, but he who hides his eyes will get many a curse" (28:27).
6. "When the righteous increase, the people rejoice, but when the wicked rule, the people groan" (29:2).

7. “Where there is no prophecy the people cast off restraint, but blessed is he who keeps the law” (29:18).

8. “The fear of man lays a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is safe” (29:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first verse of chapter 28 describes a mark of conscience. The wicked run when no one is chasing them, because guilt is its own pursuer. The righteous are bold, because they have nothing to hide. A clear conscience is a source of courage.

Verse 13 is one of the central statements on confession in the Bible: “Whoever conceals his transgressions will not prosper, but he who confesses and forsakes them will obtain mercy.” Both confession and forsaking are required. It is not enough to admit a sin and carry on. And the promise is mercy. David knew this from his own experience (Psalm 32). Hiding sin makes things worse. Confessing opens the way to mercy.

Verse 26 returns to the theme of Proverbs 3:5. “Whoever trusts in his own mind is a fool.” The wise person knows the limits of his own judgment and relies on God. The proverbs about the poor continue: generosity brings blessing, while ignoring need brings a curse. And the book’s concern for rulers appears: “A ruler who lacks understanding is a cruel oppressor, but he who hates unjust gain will prolong his days.”

Chapter 29 gives an important principle for communities: “When the righteous increase, the people rejoice, but when the wicked rule, the people groan.” The character of leaders affects the lives of ordinary people. This is why believers pray for those in authority and take care in how they choose and serve.

Verse 18 is one of the most quoted: “Where there is no prophecy the people cast off restraint.” The Hebrew word for “prophecy” means vision or revelation. When God’s word is not heard, people lose their moorings. “But blessed is he who keeps the law.” And verse 25 states the central problem of the people-pleaser: “The fear of man lays a snare.” To fear people is to be trapped. To trust the LORD is to be safe.

STEP 5

Connection

1 John 1:9 says, “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us.” Jesus is the righteous bold as a lion, the Lion of the tribe of Judah (Revelation 5:5). Jesus said, “Do not fear those who kill the body” (Matthew 10:28). Paul says, “If I were still trying to please man, I would not be a servant of Christ” (Galatians 1:10). Amos 8:11 describes a famine of hearing the words of the LORD.

STEP 6

Application

Confess one thing you have been concealing, and turn from it.

Ask whose approval you fear most. Bring it to the LORD.

Pray for the leaders in your community, that righteousness would increase.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess and forsake a sin before God.
- Ask him to keep you from the fear of man.
- Ask him to make you bold because you are clean before him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 46

"Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised."

PROVERBS 31:30

DAY 320 · WEEK 46

Proverbs 30:1-31:31

Agur's words; King Lemuel; the excellent wife

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Proverbs 30:1-31:31. The book ends with the words of Agur, the words of King Lemuel, and the famous poem of the excellent wife. Read the final poem as the capstone of the book, and ask who she really is.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 30 is attributed to Agur, an otherwise unknown man, and includes numerical sayings and a prayer. Chapter 31 begins with what a queen mother taught her son the king, and ends with an acrostic poem in praise of "an excellent wife." It is the final word of Proverbs. Since the book opened with wisdom as a woman calling in the street, it closes with a portrait of wisdom lived out.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Surely I am more brutish than any man. I have not the understanding of a man" (30:2).
2. "Who has ascended to heaven and come down?... What is his name, and what is his son's name? Surely you know!" (30:4).
3. "Every word of God proves true; he is a shield to those who take refuge in him" (30:5).
4. "Give me neither poverty nor riches; feed me with the food that is needful for me" (30:8).
5. "Open your mouth for the mute, for the rights of all who are destitute" (31:8).
6. "An excellent wife who can find? She is far more precious than jewels" (31:10).
7. "Strength and dignity are her clothing, and she laughs at the time to come" (31:25).

8 “Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised” (31:30).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Agur begins with a confession of humility, almost despairing. He claims no wisdom. He then asks rhetorical questions about who has ascended into heaven and gathered the wind in his fists, “What is his name, and what is his son’s name?” The questions point to the mystery of God. He knows his limits. And then comes a statement of faith: “Every word of God proves true; he is a shield to those who take refuge in him.” The proper response to our limits is not despair but trust in God’s word.

Agur’s prayer in verses 7 to 9 is a model of balanced petition. “Give me neither poverty nor riches.” He fears wealth, lest he deny God, and poverty, lest he steal. It shows self-knowledge. He asks for enough. The numerical sayings that follow, “Three things are too wonderful for me… four I do not understand,” show wonder at creation.

The words of King Lemuel are a mother’s teaching to her son. She warns against indulgence and calls him to speak up for those who have no voice. “Open your mouth for the mute.” A good ruler is an advocate for the helpless.

The final poem, the “excellent wife,” is an acrostic, each line beginning with the next letter of the Hebrew alphabet, a completeness from A to Z. She is a woman of strength, wisdom, industry, generosity, and fear of the LORD. She works with her hands, manages her household, trades, invests, gives to the poor, and teaches with kindness. The poem is not a checklist of tasks a woman must do. It is a portrait of wisdom embodied. The word “excellent” is the same word used elsewhere for a “mighty” warrior. It is a picture of valor.

The key line is verse 30: “Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised.” The book ends where it started: with the fear of the LORD. Wisdom is not an abstraction. It takes shape in a life lived under God.

STEP 5

Connection

Agur’s question, “Who has ascended to heaven and come down?” finds its answer in Christ (John 3:13; Ephesians 4:9-10). “Every word of God proves true” is echoed in Jesus’ trust in the Scriptures (Matthew 5:18). Ephesians 5:25-27 shows Christ’s love for the church as a bride. Jesus said, “Give us this day our daily bread” (Matthew 6:11), the prayer of Agur’s “food that is needful.”

STEP 6

Application

Pray Agur's prayer: ask God for "enough" and not too much or too little.

Whether man or woman, read the Proverbs 31 poem as a portrait of wisdom to imitate.

Speak up for someone who has no voice this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that every word of his proves true.

Ask him for neither poverty nor riches but what you need.

Ask him to teach you to open your mouth for those who cannot speak for themselves.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 46

"Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised."

PROVERBS 31:30

DAY 321 · WEEK 46

Ecclesiastes 1:1-2:26

Vanity of vanities; the futility of wisdom and pleasure

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ecclesiastes 1:1-2:26. The tone changes sharply from Proverbs. Read slowly, and let the Preacher's honesty about life sink in. Do not rush to resolve it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ecclesiastes is the book of the Preacher (Hebrew Qoheleth), "the son of David, king in Jerusalem," traditionally taken to be Solomon. If Proverbs says that wisdom leads to life, Ecclesiastes asks what happens when life seems not to add up. The key word is "vanity," literally "breath" or "vapor." The Preacher explores life "under the sun," that is, as seen from a purely earthly viewpoint, and comes back with hard truths. This is the second book of the wisdom collection, and it is an honest companion to Proverbs.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Vanity of vanities, says the Preacher, vanity of vanities! All is vanity" (1:2).
2. "What does man gain by all the toil at which he toils under the sun?" (1:3).
3. "A generation goes, and a generation comes, but the earth remains forever" (1:4).
4. "What has been is what will be, and what has been done is what will be done, and there is nothing new under the sun" (1:9).
5. "For in much wisdom is much vexation, and he who increases knowledge increases sorrow" (1:18).
6. He tries pleasure, laughter, wine, great works, wealth, and music (2:1-8).
7. "Then I considered all that my hands had done... and behold, all was vanity and a striving after wind" (2:11).

8 “There is nothing better for a person than that he should eat and drink and find enjoyment in his toil. This also, I saw, is from the hand of God” (2:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first line stuns the reader: “Vanity of vanities! All is vanity.” The word “vanity” (hebel) means a breath, a vapor, something that cannot be grasped. The Preacher is not saying that life is meaningless in every way, but that it is fleeting and elusive, impossible to hold. His starting question is: what does a person gain from all his work? If all work ends in death and is forgotten, what is the point?

He observes nature: the sun rises and sets, the wind circles, the streams run to the sea, and nothing is ever finished. History repeats. There is “nothing new under the sun.” The human heart is not satisfied by seeing and hearing. These lines describe the weariness of life without a larger purpose.

In chapter 2, the Preacher conducts an experiment. He tries pleasure, laughter, wine. He builds houses and gardens, gathers silver and gold, and has everything his eyes desire. And at the end of it, “Behold, all was vanity and a striving after wind.” He does not deny that these things are enjoyable. He says they cannot satisfy. Wisdom is better than folly, as light is better than darkness, but the same fate comes to both. The wise man dies like the fool.

This is a painful honesty. The Preacher does not offer easy answers. He lays out the problem: a life lived only for what this world offers, even in the best circumstances, ends in frustration. Death is the great leveler.

But the chapter ends with a hint of something else: “There is nothing better than that he should eat and drink and find enjoyment in his toil. This also, I saw, is from the hand of God.” Enjoyment is possible, but only as a gift received from God, not as something grasped. This is the first note of a theme that runs through the book.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that creation was “subjected to futility” in hope of liberation (Romans 8:20-21), echoing the Preacher’s vanity. Jesus asked, “What does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul?” (Mark 8:36). In Christ, our labor “is not in vain” (1 Corinthians 15:58). Jesus is the one who gives the satisfaction that nothing under the sun can: “Whoever drinks of the water that I will give him will never be thirsty” (John 4:14).

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you are chasing that cannot satisfy. Be honest.

Receive one ordinary joy today (a meal, a conversation) as a gift from God's hand.

Do not rush past the question of futility. Let it drive you to Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you tend to chase that leaves you empty.
- Ask him to satisfy you in himself.
- Ask him to teach you to receive eating, drinking, and work as gifts.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 46

"Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised."

PROVERBS 31:30

DAY 322 · WEEK 46

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Proverbs 31:30 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised."

PROVERBS 31:30

REST

Meditation

This verse is the last great statement of the book of Proverbs. It sums up the portrait of the excellent wife, and it says what matters most.

"Charm is deceitful." Charm is the ability to win people with a pleasant manner. It can be real and it can be a cover. It can hide a hollow heart. We have all known people who were delightful and untrustworthy. Charm alone is not a foundation.

"And beauty is vain." The word "vain" is the same as "vanity" in Ecclesiastes: a breath that passes. Beauty fades. In a culture that prizes appearance, this verse says that it cannot bear the weight we put on it. This is not a criticism of beauty as such, which the Bible celebrates. It is a warning against making it the measure of a life.

“But a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised.” This is the heart of it. The thing that lasts is a heart that fears the LORD. The book that began with “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge” ends with the same note. Everything in the long poem of the excellent wife flows from this root. Her strength, her generosity, her wisdom, and her laughter at the days to come grow from it.

Although the verse speaks of a woman, the principle applies to every person. Whatever we are tempted to rely on, charm, looks, talent, or position, will fade. What endures is a life oriented toward God.

For the Christian, the fear of the LORD is fulfilled in a living faith in Christ, who calls us to a beauty that does not fade (1 Peter 3:3-4). Ask God to make this the thing you want to be known for.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished Proverbs and began Ecclesiastes. You read the Sayings of the Wise, with their call to rescue those being led to death and their promise that the righteous falls seven times and rises again. You read the collection copied by Hezekiah’s men, with the proverb that iron sharpens iron and the command to feed an enemy. You saw how confession brings mercy, how the fear of man is a snare, and how Agur prayed for neither poverty nor riches. You ended Proverbs with the excellent wife, the portrait of wisdom lived out. Then Ecclesiastes opened with its stark verdict: vanity of vanities. In Psalm 119 you read of the sweetness of God’s word and its power to give understanding. The week taught that wisdom is lived out in speech, friendship, justice, and generosity, and that nothing under the sun satisfies without God.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Proverbs 28:13 says, “Whoever conceals his transgressions will not prosper, but he who confesses and forsakes them will obtain mercy.” What do you need to bring into the light this week?

Proverbs 31 ends with the fear of the LORD as the root of a praiseworthy life, and Christ is the one who lived it perfectly. How does his life give you both a model and a Savior?

The Preacher says that everything under the sun is vanity. What is one thing you have been expecting to satisfy you that cannot?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to make the fear of him your root.

Tell him where you have trusted charm, beauty, or achievement.

Thank Christ for satisfying what nothing else can.

DAY 323 · WEEK 47

Ecclesiastes 3:1-4:16

A time for everything; oppression and friendship

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 38 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ecclesiastes 3:1-4:16. This includes the famous poem about time and the Preacher's reflections on oppression, envy, and companionship. Read the poem slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Preacher continues his reflection. Having seen that effort alone cannot satisfy, he now considers the structure of time itself. Chapter 3 is among the most quoted passages in the Bible, and chapter 4 returns to the harsh realities of oppression and loneliness, and offers a consolation in the value of friendship.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For everything there is a season, and a time for every matter under heaven" (3:1).
2. "A time to be born, and a time to die… a time to weep, and a time to laugh… a time to mourn, and a time to dance" (3:2-4).
3. "He has made everything beautiful in its time" (3:11).
4. "Also, he has put eternity into man's heart, yet so that he cannot find out what God has done from the beginning to the end" (3:11).
5. "I perceived that there is nothing better for them than to be joyful and to do good as long as they live" (3:12).
6. "I perceived that whatever God does endures forever" (3:14).
7. "And I saw all the oppressions that are done under the sun. And behold, the tears of the oppressed, and they had no one to comfort them" (4:1).
8. "Two are better than one, because they have a good reward for their toil" (4:9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The poem of times is a catalog of fourteen pairs of opposite experiences: birth and death, planting and uprooting, weeping and laughing, embracing and refraining. It affirms that life has seasons, and that God governs them. It is not saying that all things are good, but that there is a time for everything, including grief. We are not meant to be always joyful or always sorrowful. Wisdom discerns the time.

The central statement is verse 11. God has made everything beautiful in its time. And he has put "eternity into man's heart." We have a sense of something beyond the present. We long for the permanent in a world of passing things. But we cannot see the whole picture. We live in the middle of the story and cannot grasp its end. This is why we are restless. The longing for eternity is a pointer to God. We are made for more than this world offers.

The Preacher's response is not despair but a call to receive life as a gift: be joyful, do good, eat and drink, and see it as the gift of God. And he reminds us of a comforting truth: "Whatever God does endures forever." Human works fade, but God's work stands. "God has done it, so that people fear before him."

Chapter 4 gives an honest view of injustice. The oppressed weep, and "they had no one to comfort them." The Preacher is moved by it, and he does not offer a quick answer. He sees envy driving much of human labor and sees the loneliness of those who work without end.

The balance comes in the section on companionship. "Two are better than one." If one falls, the other lifts him. Two keep warm. And the line, "A threefold cord is not quickly broken," has become a proverb for marriage and friendship. In a world of vapor, relationships are among the few things that give strength.

STEP 5

Connection

Galatians 4:4 says, "When the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son." The time of Christ's coming was God's chosen time. Jesus wept (John 11:35) and danced no less with joy (Luke 15:25-32), and entered all the seasons of human experience. Romans 8:18-25 describes our groaning as we wait. Jesus sent his disciples out two by two (Luke 10:1). Hebrews 10:24-25 urges believers not to neglect meeting together.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what season you are in. What is God asking of you in it?

Notice the "eternity" longing in your heart, and let it point you to God.

Think of a friend you can strengthen or lean on this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you discern the season you are in.
- Thank him for putting eternity in your heart.
- Pray for the oppressed, and ask what he would have you do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 47

"The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

DAY 324 · WEEK 47

Psalm 49

Why should I fear in times of trouble?, Ecclesiastes in the Psalter

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 49. This psalm is a wisdom psalm and a reflection on death and wealth. It is close to Ecclesiastes in tone. Read it as a sermon.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 49 is a psalm of the sons of Korah. It begins like a wisdom teacher's address to all peoples, rich and poor, and it takes up the same problem Ecclesiastes explores: all human beings die, whatever their wealth. It also gives an answer that Ecclesiastes only hints at: God will ransom the faithful from Sheol. It is placed here as the Psalter's echo of the Preacher.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hear this, all peoples! Give ear, all inhabitants of the world, both low and high, rich and poor together!" (vv. 1-2).
2. "My mouth shall speak wisdom; the meditation of my heart shall be understanding" (v. 3).
3. "Why should I fear in the days of evil, when the iniquity of my persecutors surrounds me?" (v. 5).
4. "Truly no man can ransom another, or give to God the price of his life" (v. 7).
5. "Man in his pomp will not remain; he is like the beasts that perish" (v. 12).
6. "Like sheep they are appointed for Sheol; Death shall be their shepherd" (v. 14).
7. "But God will ransom my soul from the power of Sheol, for he will receive me" (v. 15).
8. "Be not afraid when a man becomes rich, when the glory of his house increases. For when he dies he will carry nothing away" (vv. 16-17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a universal audience. It is not for Israel only but for all the inhabitants of the world. The question it addresses concerns everyone: why fear when the wealthy and powerful seem to have the upper hand? The answer is death. “No man can ransom another.” Not even the richest can buy his way out of the grave. “For he sees that even the wise die.” Wealth, wisdom, and fame all end in the same place.

The psalm describes the false confidence of the wealthy. They name lands after themselves. They trust in their riches and boast of their abundance. But “man in his pomp will not remain.” He is like the beasts. The psalm uses a shocking image: death is their shepherd, leading them like sheep to Sheol. They are being herded, not leading.

Then comes the great turn in verse 15. “But God will ransom my soul from the power of Sheol, for he will receive me.” It is one of the clearest statements of hope beyond death in the Old Testament. The word “ransom” recalls the failure of human ransom in verse 7. No man can ransom another, but God can. And “he will receive me” uses the same verb that was used of Enoch and Elijah being taken by God. It points to a hope of life with God beyond the grave.

The psalm ends with a call not to fear. Do not be afraid when the wicked prosper. They will leave everything behind. Their glory does not follow them. The wise person is not envious of what will be taken away.

This psalm answers the problem of vanity with the hope of ransom. It sees death clearly, but it does not end there.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “The Son of Man came… to give his life as a ransom for many” (Mark 10:45), the ransom no one else could pay. Paul says, “We brought nothing into the world, and we cannot take anything out of it” (1 Timothy 6:7). Hosea 13:14 and 1 Corinthians 15:54-57 speak of victory over Sheol. Jesus told the story of the rich fool (Luke 12:16-21), and said, “What will a man give in return for his soul?” (Mark 8:37).

STEP 6

Application

Do not envy someone who is wealthy. Ask what they will carry with them.

Thank Jesus for being the ransom that no man could pay.

Hold your possessions loosely, knowing that God will receive you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for giving his life as a ransom for you.

Tell God what you tend to trust in besides him, such as wealth or reputation.

Ask him to loosen your fear of death.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 47

"The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

DAY 325 · WEEK 47

Psalm 73

Truly God is good, Asaph almost slips; then sees the end

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 73. It is the story of a believer who almost lost his faith when he saw the wicked prosper. Notice the turning point in verses 16 and 17.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 73 opens Book III of the Psalter and is attributed to Asaph, a Levite who led worship in David's time. It deals with the problem Job and Ecclesiastes raise: why do the wicked prosper while the righteous suffer? The psalmist tells his own story of almost slipping. It is placed here as the Psalter's best answer to the Preacher's puzzles.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Truly God is good to Israel, to those who are pure in heart" (v. 1).
2. "But as for me, my feet had almost stumbled, my steps had nearly slipped" (v. 2).
3. "For I was envious of the arrogant when I saw the prosperity of the wicked" (v. 3).
4. "All in vain have I kept my heart clean and washed my hands in innocence" (v. 13).
5. "But when I thought how to understand this, it seemed to me a wearisome task, until I went into the sanctuary of God; then I discerned their end" (vv. 16-17).
6. "I was brutish and ignorant; I was like a beast toward you" (v. 22).
7. "Nevertheless, I am continually with you; you hold my right hand. You guide me with your counsel, and afterward you will receive me to glory" (vv. 23-24).
8. "Whom have I in heaven but you? And there is nothing on earth that I desire besides you. My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever" (vv. 25-26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a creed: “Truly God is good.” Then the psalmist admits that he almost lost it. He looked at the wicked, who had no pangs and bodies that were fat and sleek, free from trouble, mocking God, and he envied them. He wondered whether his own faithfulness had been pointless. “All in vain have I kept my heart clean.” Many believers have felt this. The Bible lets us say it out loud.

The turning point is a small phrase: “until I went into the sanctuary of God.” The solution to his problem was not a better argument, but worship. In God’s presence, he saw the whole picture: “then I discerned their end.” The wicked are on slippery ground and will be destroyed in a moment. They are like a dream when one awakes. What looked solid is a vapor. Perspective changes everything when we see it from God’s point of view.

The psalmist then confesses how foolish he had been: “I was brutish and ignorant; I was like a beast toward you.” His envy had been irrational. But he does not stop there. His confession leads to the greatest statement of the psalm: “Nevertheless, I am continually with you; you hold my right hand.” The “nevertheless” is the pivot. Despite his ignorance, God held him. His security rests not on his grip on God but on God’s grip on him.

Verses 25 and 26 are among the most beautiful in the Bible. “Whom have I in heaven but you?” God himself is the treasure. “My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever.” The psalmist ends by saying, “For me it is good to be near God.” This is the answer to the problem of the prosperity of the wicked: God himself is the reward. And with that, the psalmist sees that the wicked, though rich, have nothing.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “What does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul?” (Mark 8:36). The sanctuary where the psalmist found perspective is fulfilled in Christ, in whom we have access to God (Hebrews 10:19-22). The poor man Lazarus and the rich man (Luke 16:19-31) illustrate verses 17 to 20. Philippians 3:8 expresses the same treasure: “I count everything as loss because of the surpassing worth of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord.”

STEP 6

Application

Think about whom you have envied. Bring it into the sanctuary of God and ask for his perspective.

Pray verses 25 and 26 slowly, and ask whether they are true for you.

When you feel like you are slipping, remember that God holds your right hand.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess your envy of those who seem to prosper.
- Tell him what you see differently in his presence.
- Tell him he is the strength of your heart and your portion.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 47

"The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

DAY 326 · WEEK 47

Ecclesiastes 5:1-7:29

Fear God; wealth's emptiness; wisdom's limits

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ecclesiastes 5:1-7:29. These chapters include advice on worship, the problem of wealth, and reflections on wisdom and death. Notice the practical tone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Preacher shifts from observation to counsel. After describing the futility of life under the sun, he offers advice on how to live well within it. He speaks of approaching God, the limits of wealth, and the value of mourning. The tone is sober, and the advice is realistic. It is the voice of an experienced teacher.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Guard your steps when you go to the house of God. To draw near to listen is better than to offer the sacrifice of fools" (5:1).
2. "God is in heaven and you are on earth. Therefore let your words be few" (5:2).
3. "He who loves money will not be satisfied with money, nor he who loves wealth with his income" (5:10).
4. "As he came from his mother's womb he shall go again, naked as he came, and shall take nothing for his toil" (5:15).
5. "Every man also to whom God has given wealth and possessions and power to enjoy them, and to accept his lot and rejoice in his toil, this is the gift of God" (5:19).
6. "It is better to go to the house of mourning than to go to the house of feasting, for this is the end of all mankind, and the living will lay it to heart" (7:2).

7. “In the day of prosperity be joyful, and in the day of adversity consider: God has made the one as well as the other” (7:14).

8. “Surely there is no one on earth who is righteous, who does good and never sins” (7:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Preacher begins with worship. “Guard your steps when you go to the house of God.” He warns against thoughtless religion: hurried words, empty vows, and the “sacrifice of fools.” To listen is better than to offer. “God is in heaven and you are on earth. Therefore let your words be few.” It is the posture of reverence. We approach a holy God with humility and attention, not with a flood of words.

The long section on wealth makes several observations. Money does not satisfy: “He who loves money will not be satisfied.” The more one has, the more people there are to consume it. Wealth can be lost in a bad venture. And at death, one leaves with nothing. The Preacher has no patience for the idea that riches bring security. Yet he does not say wealth is evil. The gift is that God enables a person to enjoy what he has. “This is the gift of God.” The ability to enjoy is itself a gift.

Chapter 7 gathers a series of “better than” sayings that seem strange at first. Better to go to the house of mourning than to a feast. Better sorrow than laughter. Better the rebuke of a wise man than the song of fools. The reason is that grief teaches. A funeral reminds us of the end and makes us wise. Those who avoid thinking about death live carelessly.

The Preacher gives an honest comment on the limits of wisdom. He tried to be wise, but it was “far from me.” He admits that there is much he cannot understand. He also says that God has made both prosperity and adversity, and that we cannot predict the future. The wise do not demand to know everything.

The chapter ends with a sober statement of human sinfulness: “No one on earth is righteous, who does good and never sins.” And with a key diagnosis: “God made man upright, but they have sought out many schemes.” The problem is not creation but the Fall.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Ecclesiastes 7:20 in the same spirit in Romans 3:10-12. Jesus warned against empty words in prayer (Matthew 6:7). 1 Timothy 6:6-10 says that godliness with contentment is great gain, and that the love of money is the root of all kinds of evils. Jesus said, “Blessed are those who mourn” (Matthew 5:4). He is the one who is without sin (Hebrews 4:15), the righteous one the Preacher could not find.

STEP 6

Application

Before your next time of worship or prayer, slow down. Listen before you speak.

Ask whether money is satisfying you or driving you. Practice contentment today.

Sit with mortality for a few minutes. What does it teach you about how to live?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to teach you to listen more than you speak.
- Ask him to keep you from loving money.
- Tell him where you want to be satisfied in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 47

"The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

DAY 327 · WEEK 47

Ecclesiastes 8:1-10:20

Wisdom and rulers; death levels all; folly's cost

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ecclesiastes 8:1-10:20. The Preacher considers the injustice of life, the fate of death that comes to all, and the limits of human wisdom. Read with patience. These are some of the book's hardest passages.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Preacher continues his reflection with an eye on rulers and justice. He sees that the wicked sometimes prosper and the righteous suffer, that death comes to everyone, and that wisdom does not always bring rewards. At the same time, he repeatedly calls the reader to enjoy life as a gift. These chapters are among the most puzzling and most honest in the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Though a sinner does evil a hundred times and prolongs his life, yet I know that it will be well with those who fear God" (8:12).
2. "There is a vanity that takes place on earth, that there are righteous people to whom it happens according to the deeds of the wicked" (8:14).
3. "It is the same for all, since the same event happens to the righteous and the wicked" (9:2).
4. "A living dog is better than a dead lion" (9:4).
5. "Go, eat your bread with joy, and drink your wine with a merry heart, for God has already approved what you do" (9:7).
6. "Whatever your hand finds to do, do it with your might, for there is no work or thought or knowledge or wisdom in Sheol, to which you are going" (9:10).

7. “The race is not to the swift, nor the battle to the strong… but time and chance happen to them all” (9:11).

8. “Dead flies make the perfumer’s ointment give off a stench; so a little folly outweighs wisdom and honor” (10:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Preacher is troubled by injustice. He sees wicked people buried with honor, and righteous people receiving what the wicked deserve. “There is a vanity that takes place on earth.” He does not hide it. Yet he holds fast to a central conviction: “It will be well with those who fear God.” He cannot see how, but he knows that God is just. This is faith in the dark.

Chapter 9 faces death head-on. The same fate comes to all. The living know they will die, but the dead know nothing. Our loves and hates and envies perish. This is how it looks from “under the sun,” the perspective of observation without revelation. The Preacher is describing the limits of what can be seen. He does not yet have the fullness of the resurrection hope.

Yet in the face of death, he gives a surprising command: enjoy life. “Go, eat your bread with joy.” Enjoy your wife, “all the days of your vain life.” And “whatever your hand finds to do, do it with your might.” The shortness of life is not a reason for despair but for diligence and joy. Because we will not be here forever, we should live fully now and work wholeheartedly.

He also says that life is not predictable: “The race is not to the swift.” Time and chance happen to everyone. We cannot guarantee outcomes. The Preacher does not deny God’s sovereignty, but he refuses to turn the proverbs into promises. Wisdom is valuable, but no one can control how things turn out.

Chapter 10 returns to the practical, with sayings about folly and rulers. A little folly spoils much wisdom. “The words of a wise man’s mouth win him favor, but the lips of a fool consume him.” The chapter shows that wisdom matters even though it does not guarantee success.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that Christ has “abolished death and brought life and immortality to light through the gospel” (2 Timothy 1:10), answering the Preacher’s darkness. 1 Corinthians 15:58 says, “Your labor is not in vain in the Lord.” Jesus spoke of working “while it is day” (John 9:4). Colossians 3:23 echoes 9:10: “Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord.” Revelation 14:13 says the dead who die in the Lord rest from their labors and their deeds follow them.

STEP 6

Application

Enjoy one simple pleasure today, with thanks to God.

Do a task you have been avoiding with all your might.

If you are troubled by injustice, bring it to God, who is just even when you cannot see it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give God what you do not understand about life under the sun.

Ask him to teach you to enjoy his gifts with thanks and humility.

Ask him to keep you from folly's small costs.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 47

"The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

DAY 328 · WEEK 47

Ecclesiastes 11:1-12:14

Remember your Creator; fear God and keep his commandments

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ecclesiastes 11:1-12:14. The Preacher's final words call the young to remember their Creator, describe old age, and give the conclusion of the whole book. Read the last two verses slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The book comes to its end. After exploring the vanity of life under the sun, the Preacher now speaks to the young, then to the old, and then gives his closing verdict. An unnamed editor adds a few words about the Preacher. The conclusion is the key to the entire book and answers the question "What is the point?"

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Cast your bread upon the waters, for you will find it after many days" (11:1).
2. "As you do not know the way the spirit comes to the bones in the womb of a woman with child, so you do not know the work of God who makes everything" (11:5).
3. "Rejoice, O young man, in your youth, and let your heart cheer you in the days of your youth... But know that for all these things God will bring you into judgment" (11:9).
4. "Remember also your Creator in the days of your youth, before the evil days come" (12:1).
5. The poem of old age: the keepers of the house tremble, the grinders cease, the almond tree blossoms, the silver cord is snapped (12:3-6).
6. "And the dust returns to the earth as it was, and the spirit returns to God who gave it" (12:7).

7 “The words of the wise are like goads, and like nails firmly fixed are the collected sayings; they are given by one Shepherd” (12:11).

8 “The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man. For God will bring every deed into judgment, with every secret thing, whether good or evil” (12:13-14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 11 is an encouragement to generosity and bold action. “Cast your bread upon the waters.” Take risks in giving and investing, because you cannot know what will come. The one who waits for perfect conditions never sows or reaps. We cannot know the work of God, so we should act in faith and diligence. “In the morning sow your seed, and at evening withhold not your hand.”

The Preacher then speaks to the young. “Rejoice in your youth.” He does not tell the young to be glum. But he adds a sobering note: God will bring you into judgment. Joy and accountability go together. And in chapter 12, he gives the command: “Remember your Creator in the days of your youth.” Do it before it is too late, before the “evil days” of old age come.

The poem on old age is one of the most moving in the Bible. It describes a house falling apart: the trembling of the arms, the stooping of the legs, the loss of teeth, dimming eyes, deafness, fear of heights, white hair, and finally death, when “the silver cord is snapped.” It is a vivid portrait of how bodies fail. Its purpose is not morbid but sobering: remember your Creator now.

The last words give the book’s conclusion: “Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man.” After exploring everything under the sun, the Preacher returns to the theme that began Proverbs. The answer to vanity is not found in more experience but in the fear of God. And life matters because “God will bring every deed into judgment.” Nothing is meaningless, because everything will be seen and weighed by him.

Verse 11 says that the words of the wise are like goads and nails, given by “one Shepherd.” The book of Ecclesiastes, with its challenging honesty, is part of God’s shepherding word. It pushes us toward what matters.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says, “The fear of the Lord” and judgment are intertwined: “We must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ” (2 Corinthians 5:10). Jesus is the “one Shepherd” (John 10:11, 16), the Good Shepherd who gives us the words of life. “Remember your Creator” echoes Mark 10:14-15 and 2 Timothy 3:15. The “whole duty of man” is fulfilled in Christ, who kept the commandments perfectly, and in whom we are forgiven (Romans 8:3-4).

STEP 6

Application

Do something generous without waiting for the perfect time.

If you are young, remember your Creator now. If you are older, tell someone younger what you have learned.

Write down the Preacher’s conclusion, and ask what it means for how you spend this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Remember your Creator in your own words, and thank him for something from your youth or now.

Ask him to teach you to fear him and keep his commandments.

Thank Jesus, the Good Shepherd.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 47

“The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man.”

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

DAY 329 · WEEK 47

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Ecclesiastes 12:13 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."

ECCLESIASTES 12:13

REST

Meditation

This verse is the Preacher's final answer. After twelve chapters of searching, he arrives at a conclusion that is as simple as it is demanding.

"The end of the matter; all has been heard." The Preacher says that he has finished. All the observations, experiments, and puzzles have been laid out. Now comes the summary. It is a way of saying: if you want only one thing from this book, take this.

"Fear God." The book began with "vanity," and it ends with "fear." The Preacher's long reflection shows that nothing under the sun can bear the weight of our hopes. The only stable footing is a right relationship to the God who made us. To fear God is to honor him as God, to trust him, to submit to him, and to take him seriously.

“And keep his commandments.” Fear is not just a feeling. It shows itself in obedience. The two belong together. A person who says he fears God but ignores what God says has not understood.

“For this is the whole duty of man.” The Hebrew is literally “this is the whole of man.” This is what a human being is for. It is the purpose of our existence. All the things we chase, if they are not oriented to this, are a breath.

The verse that follows adds a motive: God will bring every deed into judgment. This is both a warning and a comfort. Nothing is hidden, and nothing is wasted. For the Christian, the weight of this verse is carried by Christ. He kept God’s commandments perfectly, and he bore the judgment we deserved. We now fear God not as condemned people but as forgiven children, and we obey out of gratitude. Pray this verse as a summary of your life’s purpose.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you moved from Proverbs into the heart of Ecclesiastes. You saw the Preacher’s verdict on life under the sun: vanity of vanities, a breath. You read the poem of times and the promise that God has put eternity into our hearts. You read the Psalter’s answers to the same questions: Psalm 49, in which God ransoms the soul from Sheol, and Psalm 73, where the psalmist’s near-slip ended in the sanctuary and in the great confession, “Whom have I in heaven but you?” You followed the Preacher’s counsel on worship, wealth, mourning, and mortality, and his call to enjoy life as a gift and to work with all your might. And you reached the end of the matter: fear God and keep his commandments. The week taught that nothing under the sun satisfies, that death is real, and that God himself is our portion.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Preacher says God has “put eternity into man’s heart.” Where do you feel that longing for something more, and how does it point you to God?

Psalm 49 says no one can ransom another, but God will ransom the faithful from Sheol. How does Jesus fulfill this promise, and how does it change how you think about death?

Psalm 73 says, “Whom have I in heaven but you?” If you honestly answer that question today, what do you find?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to fear him and keep his commandments.

Thank Christ for the ransom.

Rest in him as the strength of your heart.

DAY 330 · WEEK 48

Song of Solomon 1:1-4:16

Love, desire, and covenant

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 68 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Song of Solomon 1:1-4:16. This is a love poem between a man and a woman. Read it slowly, as poetry. Do not rush to allegory or avoid it as embarrassing. First, let it be what it is.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Song of Songs, "which is Solomon's," means "the best song." It is a collection of love poems in dialogue between a bride, a bridegroom, and a chorus of friends, the "daughters of Jerusalem." It celebrates erotic love within marriage. It is placed here because the wisdom books explore how to live well in God's world, and a good marriage is one of the central gifts. The song has also been read throughout church history as a picture of Christ's love for his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth! For your love is better than wine" (1:2).
2. "I am black and lovely, O daughters of Jerusalem" (1:5).
3. "As a lily among brambles, so is my love among the young women" (2:2).
4. "He brought me to the banqueting house, and his banner over me was love" (2:4).
5. "My beloved is mine, and I am his" (2:16).
6. "I adjure you, O daughters of Jerusalem… that you not stir up or awaken love until it pleases" (2:7).
7. "You are altogether beautiful, my love; there is no flaw in you" (4:7).
8. "A garden locked is my sister, my bride, a spring locked, a fountain sealed" (4:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Song begins with desire. The woman speaks first, and her words are bold. She longs for her beloved's kisses. The Bible does not shy away from the physical side of love. The Song presents it as a good gift of God, to be celebrated within the covenant of marriage. In a world that treats sex either as shameful or as trivial, the Song says it is beautiful and holy.

The couple exchange compliments in rich poetic images that can sound strange to modern ears: eyes like doves, hair like a flock of goats, a nose like a tower of Lebanon. These were images of beauty and delight in the ancient world. The man praises the woman's beauty, and the woman praises his. They value each other. The mutuality is striking.

The refrain of 2:7, "Do not stir up or awaken love until it pleases," appears three times in the Song. It is a warning to the daughters of Jerusalem: love should not be forced or rushed. It has a time. This is a wise word for a culture that hurries into physical intimacy. Love is powerful, and it should be treated with care.

In chapter 2, the poem moves to spring. "For behold, the winter is past; the rain is over and gone. The flowers appear on the earth." Love is like the renewal of the earth. There are scenes of longing and search, of delight in the other's presence. The woman says, "My beloved is mine, and I am his." It is a statement of covenant belonging.

Chapter 3 includes a dream or search at night and the wedding procession of Solomon. Chapter 4 is the groom's long praise of his bride on their wedding night. The garden imagery, "a garden locked," speaks of purity and exclusivity. And the bride's response is an invitation: "Let my beloved come to his garden, and eat its choicest fruits." Love is both reserved and freely given.

STEP 5

Connection

Christian readers have long seen in the Song a picture of Christ and his church. Ephesians 5:25-32 calls marriage a profound mystery pointing to Christ and the church. John 3:29 says, "The one who has the bride is the bridegroom." Revelation 19:7 describes the marriage of the Lamb. At the same time, the Song stands as a celebration of human marriage in its own right. Jesus affirmed marriage as God's design from the beginning (Matthew 19:4-6).

STEP 6

Application

If you are married, speak words of praise to your spouse today.

If you are single, thank God for the gift of marriage as a picture of Christ's love.

Ask God to help you honor desire in the right time and place.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for love and for the picture of Christ and his church in marriage.

Ask him to teach you to value what he has given in its proper time.

Pray for those who are lonely or married, as it fits.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 48

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."

PROVERBS 3:5-6

DAY 331 · WEEK 48

Song of Solomon 5:1-8:14

Longing, union, and love strong as death

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Song of Solomon 5:1-8:14. The mood becomes more complex, with longing, loss, and the great declaration about love in chapter 8. Read 8:6-7 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second half of the Song continues the cycle of love poems. There is delight, but also absence and search. The woman dreams of her beloved knocking at the door and then disappearing. She searches the city and is beaten by the watchmen. The couple reunite, and the poem moves toward its conclusion with one of the most famous statements about love in all literature.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “I slept, but my heart was awake. A sound! My beloved is knocking” (5:2).
2. “I opened to my beloved, but my beloved had turned and gone” (5:6).
3. “My beloved is radiant and ruddy, distinguished among ten thousand” (5:10).
4. “I am my beloved’s and my beloved is mine; he grazes among the lilies” (6:3).
5. “Come away, my beloved, let us go out into the fields” (7:11).
6. “Set me as a seal upon your heart, as a seal upon your arm, for love is strong as death, jealousy is fierce as the grave” (8:6).
7. “Its flashes are flashes of fire, the very flame of the LORD” (8:6).
8. “Many waters cannot quench love, neither can floods drown it. If a man offered for love all the wealth of his house, he would be utterly despised” (8:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 5 opens with a scene of near-miss. The woman is in bed, and her beloved knocks, but she hesitates. By the time she opens the door, he is gone. She searches the streets and is struck by the watchmen. It is a picture of the pain of missed connection, and perhaps of the way that love can be strained by hesitation. The daughters of Jerusalem ask what is so special about her beloved, and she answers with a long praise. Love is not blind. She can say exactly why he is distinguished among ten thousand.

The poem describes reconciliation. “I am my beloved’s and my beloved is mine.” The repeated phrase is a statement of covenant belonging. In chapter 6 the man praises her as “terrible as an army with banners,” awe-inspiring. In chapter 7, the couple expresses desire and delight in the language of the vineyard and the garden. The woman invites him to the field, where she will give him her love.

The center of the whole Song is 8:6-7. “Set me as a seal upon your heart.” A seal was a mark of ownership and a pledge of identity. She wants to be marked as his, permanently. “For love is strong as death.” Death cannot be resisted. Neither can love. “Jealousy is fierce as the grave.” This is the jealousy of covenant love, which cannot share its beloved. And “its flashes are flashes of fire, the very flame of the LORD.” Some versions read, “a flame of Yah.” Love is a spark of the divine. It is one of the only places in the Song where God’s name appears.

“Many waters cannot quench love.” It is the kind of love that endures floods. And it cannot be bought. If a man tried to purchase it with all his wealth, he would be despised. Love is a gift, not a commodity.

The Song ends with the woman’s invitation: “Make haste, my beloved.” It is a note of longing that is not fully satisfied. Love in this world points beyond itself.

STEP 5

Connection

The words about love strong as death find their fullest meaning in Christ’s love, which defeated death. “Greater love has no one than this” (John 15:13). Romans 8:35-39 says that nothing, neither death nor life, can separate us from the love of God in Christ. Paul says in Ephesians 5 that Christ gave himself for his bride. Revelation 22:17 and 20 echo the final invitation: “Come, Lord Jesus.” The seal on the heart recalls Ephesians 1:13, where believers are “sealed with the promised Holy Spirit.”

STEP 6

Application

If you are married, renew your commitment to your spouse. Say, “I am yours.”

Ask God to help you love with a love that endures floods.

Think about the love of Christ, which was stronger than death, and rest in it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Christ for giving himself for his bride.

Ask him to set you as a seal on his heart, and tell him what that means.

Tell him where you long for him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 48

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."

PROVERBS 3:5-6

DAY 332 · WEEK 48

Psalm 45

The bridal song and its Messianic echo

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 45. You read this psalm in Unit 9, with attention to the king. Today read it again, this time paying special attention to the bride in verses 10 to 17 and to how the psalm echoes the Song of Solomon.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 45 is a royal wedding song, and in Unit 9 (Day 290) you read it as a portrait of the Davidic king. Now it appears at the close of the wisdom books, right after the Song of Solomon. The two works belong together. Both celebrate a royal wedding and a bridegroom's love, and both have been read by the church as a picture of Christ and his people. This time, look at the bride.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "My heart overflows with a pleasing theme; I address my verses to the king" (v. 1).
2. "Your throne, O God, is forever and ever" (v. 6).
3. "At your right hand stands the queen in gold of Ophir" (v. 9).
4. "Hear, O daughter, consider, and incline your ear: forget your people and your father's house" (v. 10).
5. "and the king will desire your beauty. Since he is your lord, bow to him" (v. 11).
6. "All glorious is the princess in her chamber, with robes interwoven with gold" (v. 13).
7. "With joy and gladness they are led along as they enter the palace of the king" (v. 15).
8. "I will cause your name to be remembered in all generations; therefore nations will praise you forever and ever" (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Unit 9 the focus was on the king: his majesty, his righteousness, and his eternal throne. Here the focus shifts to the bride. She is told to forget her people and her father's house. A wedding means leaving one family to join another. It echoes Genesis 2:24: "A man shall leave his father and his mother and hold fast to his wife." She is called to a new loyalty. The call is not a loss but a gain, because "the king will desire your beauty." Her beauty is a gift of his love.

The bride is clothed in splendor. She stands at the king's right hand in gold. She is led to the king in embroidered garments, with companions, with joy and gladness. The picture is not of a servant but of a queen. In the Song of Solomon, we saw the same mutual delight of the bridegroom and bride. In both texts, love is a covenant that transforms and glorifies.

Reading with the Song in mind, we notice how both works use the language of royalty and beauty to speak of love. The bridegroom is a king, and the bride is a queen. The ordinary becomes extraordinary. A wedding is a picture of how God loves his people.

The psalm closes with a promise concerning the king's name: "Nations will praise you forever." The love story of the king extends to the nations. What began as a royal wedding becomes a universal blessing.

Read with the whole Bible, the psalm points to Christ the King and his bride the church, a love that began in a promise and ends in a wedding feast. The wisdom books end with love, which is the end of wisdom: knowing and being known by God.

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 5:25-27 says that Christ loved the church and gave himself for her, "that he might present the church to himself in splendor." Revelation 19:7-8 shows the bride arrayed in fine linen, bright and pure. Revelation 21:2 pictures the New Jerusalem "prepared as a bride adorned for her husband." Hebrews 1:8-9 quotes verses 6 and 7 of this psalm of the Son. Jesus is the Bridegroom (Mark 2:19-20).

STEP 6

Application

Read verse 10 as a call to give your first loyalty to Christ. What does "forget your father's house" mean for you?

Thank God that the Bridegroom desires his people.

Think about how the church is being prepared for the wedding. How can you take part?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what fills your heart as you think of the King and his bride.

Ask him to teach you to give Christ your first loyalty.

Ask him to prepare his church for his coming.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 48

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."

PROVERBS 3:5-6

DAY 333 · WEEK 48

Review and Reflection

Unit 10 review, Wisdom Literature

Year 1 · Unit 10 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."
>
> PROVERBS 3:5-6

REST

Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and reflection on what you have learned in Unit 10.

Begin by memorizing the verse above if you have not already. Say it aloud several times, then try writing it from memory. These verses have been the anchor of this unit, and they sum up the instruction of the wisdom books.

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart." Wisdom begins with trust, not with technique. In Proverbs, we saw that the fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom. Trust is the same posture seen from the inside. We believe that God is good and that he knows what he is doing.

"And do not lean on your own understanding." Ecclesiastes shows what happens when we do. The Preacher explored the world with all his intelligence and found it a vapor. Psalm 73 shows a man who nearly fell because he trusted what he saw. The way that seems right to a man ends in death. Our understanding is not useless, but it cannot be our final authority.

"In all your ways acknowledge him." Not only in church, but in work, money, marriage, friendships, speech, and decisions. This is the lived side of wisdom: bringing God into everything.

“And he will make straight your paths.” This is a promise. It does not say the path will be easy. It says that God will direct it. The Song of Solomon reminds us that his love is stronger than death. The Preacher ends with fear God and keep his commandments. The Psalms say that God holds our right hand.

Think of Christ, who trusted the Father perfectly and did not lean on his own understanding, and who is himself the wisdom of God. In him, the paths of all who trust are made straight.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 10 you have read the wisdom books of the Old Testament: Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, and the Song of Solomon, along with Psalms 19, 45, 49, 73, and a long journey through Psalm 119. If the story of Israel’s history showed how God rules his people, these books show how to live in the world God made.

Proverbs opened with the fear of the LORD as the beginning of knowledge, and called the reader to choose between the way of Wisdom and the way of Folly. You read the father’s instruction to his son, the warnings about adultery, laziness, and bad company, and the beautiful alternative of faithful love. You read Wisdom’s own speech in chapter 8, where she stands beside God at creation, a poetic picture that the New Testament sees fulfilled in Christ. You read hundreds of sayings on speech, work, friendship, justice, generosity, and pride, and saw that God holds human plans in his hand. The book ended with Agur’s humility and the portrait of the excellent wife, whose praise rests on the fear of the LORD.

Ecclesiastes asked the hard questions. The Preacher looked at life under the sun and found it a breath. He tried pleasure, work, and wisdom, and found that death comes to all. Yet he did not despair. He called us to receive life as a gift from God, to enjoy and to work, and to remember that God will bring every deed into judgment. His conclusion was simple: fear God and keep his commandments. Psalms 49 and 73 gave the hope the Preacher could only glimpse: God will ransom the soul from Sheol, and he himself is our portion.

The Song of Solomon celebrated love between husband and wife as a good gift from God, and a picture of the love between Christ and his church. Its great declaration was that love is strong as death. Psalm 119 offered a long meditation on the word of God as a lamp, honey, and light. And Psalm 45 closed the unit with the royal wedding.

Together these books teach that God is not only the Lord of history but the Lord of ordinary life. They also leave us longing for the one in whom all wisdom dwells.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What is the “fear of the LORD” and why is it the beginning of wisdom?

Look back at Proverbs 1:7, 9:10, and the closing of Ecclesiastes. The fear of the LORD is reverent trust: taking God seriously as God. Write a few sentences describing what it means, and how it differs from terror. Why is it the starting point rather than an add-on? How does the cross show both the reason to fear and the reason to trust?

How does Ecclesiastes’s conclusion answer the problem of vanity?

Recall the Preacher’s long exploration of work, pleasure, wealth, and wisdom, and his verdict that all is a breath. Then recall his final words: fear God and keep his commandments, for God will bring every deed into judgment. Write about how this conclusion answers the problem. Where is the hope in the book, and where does it point beyond itself to Christ?

How does Wisdom in Proverbs 8 point us toward Christ?

Look at Proverbs 8:22-31, where Wisdom speaks of being beside God as a master workman at creation. Compare it with John 1:1-3, Colossians 1:15-17, and 1 Corinthians 1:24. Write a few sentences on how the New Testament reads this passage, and what it means that Christ is the wisdom of God. How does this change how you seek wisdom?

What is the Song of Solomon ultimately about, and how should we read it?

Think about the Song as a celebration of married love, and then about the church’s long tradition of seeing in it a picture of Christ and his people. Look at Ephesians 5:25-32. Write a few sentences on how both readings can be held together. What does the Song teach about the goodness of desire, the value of covenant, and the strength of love?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for what the wisdom books have taught you.

Tell him where you still lean on your own understanding.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 11 · DAYS 334-378

The Divided Kingdom and Early Prophets

1 Kings 12-2 Kings 17, Amos, Hosea, Jonah, Micah

The covenant fractures. God sends prophets to call his people back.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings."

HOSEA 6:6

Laments and cries for justice (42 to 44, 58, 82, 94, 109, 74, 77) beside the prophets' protests.

UNIT 11

In this unit

WEEK 48

334	1 Kings 12:1-14:20	*Reading*
335	1 Kings 14:21-16:34	*Reading*
336	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 49

337	Psalm 42	*Psalm*
338	Psalm 43	*Psalm*
339	1 Kings 17:1-19:21	*Reading*
340	1 Kings 20:1-22:53	*Reading*
341	2 Kings 1:1-2:25	*Reading*
342	2 Kings 3:1-4:44	*Reading*
343	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 50

344	Psalm 44	*Psalm*
345	Psalm 60	*Psalm*
346	2 Kings 5:1-6:33	*Reading*
347	2 Kings 7:1-8:29	*Reading*
348	2 Kings 9:1-10:36	*Reading*
349	2 Kings 11:1-13:25	*Reading*
350	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 51

351	Psalm 50	*Psalm*
352	Psalm 52; Psalm 53	*Psalm*
353	2 Kings 14:1-15:38	*Reading*
354	Amos 1:1-2:16	*Reading*
355	Amos 3:1-5:27	*Reading*

356	Amos 6:1-9:15	*Reading*
357	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 52

358	Psalm 58	*Psalm*
359	Psalm 82	*Psalm*
360	Psalm 94	*Psalm*
361	Psalm 109	*Psalm*
362	Psalm 140; Psalm 142	*Psalm*
363	Hosea 1:1-3:5	*Reading*
364	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 53

365	Hosea 4:1-7:16	*Reading*
366	Hosea 8:1-11:12	*Reading*
367	Hosea 12:1-14:9	*Reading*
368	Psalm 74	*Psalm*
369	Psalm 77	*Psalm*
370	Jonah 1:1-2:10	*Reading*
371	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 54

372	Jonah 3:1-4:11	*Reading*
373	Micah 1:1-3:12	*Reading*
374	Micah 4:1-5:15	*Reading*
375	Micah 6:1-7:20	*Reading*
376	2 Kings 16:1-17:41	*Reading*
377	Review and Reflection	*Review*
378	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 334 · WEEK 48

1 Kings 12:1-14:20

The kingdom divides; Jeroboam's golden calves

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 12:1-14:20. The kingdom splits in two, and Jeroboam makes a fateful religious decision. Read the account of Rehoboam's choice and Jeroboam's golden calves carefully, because this sin will be named again and again through the rest of Kings.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Solomon is dead, and his son Rehoboam goes to Shechem to be confirmed as king. The northern tribes ask for relief from the heavy labor and taxes Solomon imposed. What Rehoboam decides will tear the kingdom apart, as God had said through the prophet Ahijah. Around 930 BC, the nation splits into the northern kingdom of Israel under Jeroboam and the southern kingdom of Judah under Rehoboam. This begins the story of the divided kingdom.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The people say, "Your father made our yoke heavy. Now therefore lighten the hard service of your father" (12:4).
2. Rehoboam rejects the counsel of the old men who served Solomon and follows the young men (12:6-14).
3. "My father made your yoke heavy, but I will add to your yoke. My father disciplined you with whips, but I will discipline you with scorpions" (12:14).
4. "What portion do we have in David? We have no inheritance in the son of Jesse. To your tents, O Israel!" (12:16).
5. "So Israel has been in rebellion against the house of David to this day" (12:19).

6. Jeroboam says in his heart, “If this people go up to offer sacrifices in the temple of the LORD at Jerusalem, then the heart of this people will turn again to their lord” (12:26-27).
7. He makes two golden calves and says, “Behold your gods, O Israel, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt” (12:28).
8. “And this thing became a sin” (12:30).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The narrator is clear that the split was God’s doing: “It was a turn of affairs brought about by the LORD.” It was judgment on Solomon’s idolatry. But that does not excuse Rehoboam. He had the chance to serve. The old men told him, “If you will be a servant to this people today and serve them… they will be your servants forever.” It was wise advice, and it is the way of a true king. But Rehoboam chose arrogance over service, the way of Pharaoh rather than of a shepherd. A proud word split a nation.

Jeroboam received a promise. Through Ahijah, God had said that if he walked in God’s ways, he would have “an enduring house, as I built for David.” It was a remarkable offer. But Jeroboam did not trust it. He feared that if the people went to Jerusalem to worship, they would go back to Rehoboam. So he set up his own religion for political reasons: two golden calves at Bethel and Dan, his own priests, and his own festival. “He had devised from his own heart.” It was convenient, efficient, and idolatrous.

This is the “sin of Jeroboam,” and it becomes the measuring stick for every northern king after him. Notice what he did. He took the story of the exodus, “who brought you up out of the land of Egypt,” and attached it to a calf. He did not reject the LORD. He reshaped worship to suit his needs. It is a warning about religion that is designed for convenience or politics. When we decide how God should be worshiped, we are no longer following him.

Chapter 13 shows the seriousness. A man of God from Judah prophesies against the altar, but he is deceived by an old prophet and killed by a lion. The message is that obedience to God’s word must be complete. And chapter 14 ends with the death of Jeroboam’s son and the prophecy that God will “give Israel up because of the sins of Jeroboam, which he sinned and made Israel to sin.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the king who came not to be served but to serve (Mark 10:45), where Rehoboam threatened scorpions. He is the true shepherd, who united what was divided: “He himself is our peace, who has made us both one” (Ephesians 2:14). Jesus said that true worshipers “will

worship the Father in spirit and in truth" (John 4:23-24), not in a religion of our own devising. Paul warns of a religion of "self-made" worship (Colossians 2:23).

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you are tempted to answer pressure with pride instead of service.

Consider whether you have shaped your faith around convenience rather than God's word.

Pray for the unity of Christ's church, divided in many ways.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you from Rehoboam's pride and Jeroboam's convenient religion.

Ask him to teach you to serve and not to rule harshly.

Ask him to help you worship him as he has revealed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 48

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."

PROVERBS 3:5-6

DAY 335 · WEEK 48

1 Kings 14:21-16:34

A succession of unfaithful kings; Ahab and Jezebel

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 14:21-16:34. The narrative moves quickly through a series of kings in Judah and Israel. Notice the repeated formulas, and slow down at the arrival of Ahab and Jezebel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In the decades after the split, the books of Kings tell the story of both kingdoms side by side. The author uses a formula for each king: when he began to reign, how long he reigned, and a verdict on whether he did right or evil in the eyes of the LORD. In the south, Rehoboam, Abijam, and Asa reign. In the north, a succession of kings, with coups and civil war, leads to Omri and then to his son Ahab.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Judah under Rehoboam did evil: they built high places, pillars, and Asherim, and there were male cult prostitutes in the land (14:22-24).
2. Shishak king of Egypt attacks Jerusalem and takes the treasures of the temple (14:25-26).
3. “For David’s sake the LORD his God gave him a lamp in Jerusalem” (15:4).
4. “Asa did what was right in the eyes of the LORD, as David his father had done” (15:11).
5. Asa removes idols and his own mother’s position as queen mother, but “the high places were not taken away” (15:12-14).
6. Northern kings rise and fall: Nadab, Baasha, Elah, Zimri, Omri, each “walking in the way of Jeroboam” (15:25-16:28).

7. “Ahab the son of Omri did evil in the sight of the LORD, more than all who were before him” (16:30).
8. He married Jezebel, daughter of the king of Sidon, “and went and served Baal and worshiped him” (16:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The summaries can seem repetitive, but the repetition teaches. In the north, king after king “walked in the way of Jeroboam.” No dynasty lasts. Baasha kills Nadab. Zimri kills Elah and reigns seven days before burning his own palace. Omri comes to power. The northern kingdom is unstable because it is built on a false foundation. Without the Davidic promise, it has no secure line.

In the south, the pattern is different. Even when kings are bad, there is a recurring phrase: “for David’s sake the LORD gave him a lamp in Jerusalem.” God’s faithfulness to the covenant with David continues. A lamp is a small light, but it does not go out. Judah’s survival, in spite of its unfaithful kings, is a sign of grace.

Asa stands out as a reformer. He removes idols and even deposes his grandmother for making an image of Asherah. It is a costly act of obedience. But his reform is incomplete, because the high places remain. And later, when threatened by Baasha, Asa will turn to a foreign king rather than to the LORD (2 Chronicles 16). Even the best kings have limits.

Chapter 16 introduces the worst. Ahab is described as doing evil “more than all who were before him.” The narrator says it was a “light thing” for him to walk in the sins of Jeroboam. He went further and married Jezebel, a Sidonian princess devoted to Baal, and built a temple and altar for Baal in Samaria. The northern kingdom is now officially committed to a foreign god of storms and fertility.

The chapter ends with a detail that reaches back to Joshua. Hiel of Bethel rebuilds Jericho “at the cost of Abiram his firstborn,” fulfilling Joshua’s curse. God’s word does not fail. The same word that brought the walls down still stands.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the Davidic king whose light is not a small lamp but the light of the world (John 8:12). Where the kings of Israel and Judah failed one after another, he is the one faithful king. Matthew 6:24 states that no one can serve two masters, a truth Ahab’s reign illustrated. 1 John 5:21 says, “Little children, keep yourselves from idols.”

STEP 6

Application

Ask what “high places” remain in your life, areas you have not fully surrendered.

Thank God for the lamp he keeps burning for his promises.

Consider how easily “light things” become heavy. What small compromise do you tolerate?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for keeping a lamp burning for the sake of his promise.

Ask him to keep you from half-obedience and the high places you leave standing.

Ask him to help you serve him alone.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 48

“Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths.”

PROVERBS 3:5-6

DAY 336 · WEEK 48

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Proverbs 3:5-6 once more, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."

PROVERBS 3:5-6

REST

Meditation

You memorized this verse in the last unit. Today, return to it with the opening of the divided kingdom in mind.

Rehoboam leaned on his own understanding. He took the counsel of his young friends and refused the advice of the elders. The result was a torn nation. Jeroboam leaned on his own understanding too. He feared losing his people and invented a new religion. The result was a sin that haunted a kingdom for two hundred years. Both are living illustrations of what happens when we do not trust the LORD with all our heart.

The verse does not say that thinking is bad. It says that our own understanding is not the final guide. We are limited. We cannot see the future. We cannot see the heart of another. We cannot be sure of our own motives. When we rest our whole weight on what seems wise to us, we are in danger.

“In all your ways acknowledge him.” Rehoboam did not consult God. He did not ask. Jeroboam did not ask either. He worked out a plan that made sense politically. But acknowledging the LORD means bringing him into the decision, before we act. It means asking, “What has God said?”

“And he will make straight your paths.” Note that this is a promise for those who trust. God will direct the paths. This is a comfort for anyone who has made a mess of things. It is not too late to begin trusting.

Hold this verse as the unit moves into a darker period. In a time of idolatry and violence, the way to stay faithful is not to rely on our own cleverness but on the LORD.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week the united kingdom of David and Solomon came apart. You read of Rehoboam’s proud answer and Jeroboam’s golden calves, and the sin of Jeroboam that became the standard of evil for the northern kings. You saw how God kept a lamp for David’s sake in Jerusalem, even as Judah’s kings failed. You followed the quick succession of northern kings, with their coups, until Ahab and Jezebel brought Baal worship into the heart of Israel. The week taught that a proud word can tear a nation, that convenient religion is idolatry, and that God keeps his promises to David even when his people do not keep theirs.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Rehoboam refused the counsel of the elders. Who are the wise people in your life, and are you listening to them?

God kept a lamp burning for David’s sake even when Judah’s kings failed. How does Christ, the true Son of David, give you confidence that God keeps his promises?

Jeroboam designed a religion that was convenient. Where are you tempted to adjust your faith to fit your comfort?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you trust him with all your heart, and name one thing you lean on yourself for.

Thank him for keeping his promises to David and for Christ the true king.

Rest in him today.

DAY 337 · WEEK 49

Psalm 42

As a deer pants for flowing streams

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 42. It is the cry of a person who longs for God in a time of depression and exile. Pay attention to how the psalmist talks to his own soul.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 42 opens Book II of the Psalter and is attributed to the sons of Korah. The psalmist is far from the temple, "from the land of Jordan and of Hermon," in the far north. He is cut off from worship and surrounded by taunts. Placed here, at the beginning of the divided kingdom, it speaks for believers who feel the loss of the true worship of God. Psalms 42 and 43 are really one poem with a repeated refrain.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "As a deer pants for flowing streams, so pants my soul for you, O God" (v. 1).
2. "My soul thirsts for God, for the living God. When shall I come and appear before God?" (v. 2).
3. "My tears have been my food day and night, while they say to me all the day long, Where is your God?" (v. 3).
4. "These things I remember, as I pour out my soul: how I would go with the throng and lead them in procession to the house of God" (v. 4).
5. "Why are you cast down, O my soul, and why are you in turmoil within me? Hope in God; for I shall again praise him, my salvation and my God" (v. 5).
6. "Deep calls to deep at the roar of your waterfalls; all your breakers and your waves have gone over me" (v. 7).

7. “By day the LORD commands his steadfast love, and at night his song is with me, a prayer to the God of my life” (v. 8).

8. “I say to God, my rock: Why have you forgotten me?” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with one of the most beautiful images in the Bible: a deer in a drought, panting for water. The word “pants” conveys urgency. The animal’s life depends on finding a stream. The psalmist’s soul feels the same need for God. It is not a mild interest in religion. It is a thirst that cannot be satisfied by anything else.

The cause of his pain is twofold. First, he is cut off from the community of worshipers. He remembers going with the crowd to the house of God, with shouts of joy and thanksgiving. Now it is only a memory. Second, he faces mockery: “Where is your God?” The question is cruel because the psalmist himself half wonders. In times of suffering, God’s absence feels real.

What the psalmist does next is crucial. He talks to himself. “Why are you cast down, O my soul?” He does not simply give in to his feelings. He questions them. He addresses his soul as a person to be instructed. And he gives it an instruction: “Hope in God.” The refrain appears three times in Psalms 42 and 43, as though the psalmist must say it over and over. Faith is sometimes a matter of preaching to oneself.

Verse 7 is one of the most haunting: “Deep calls to deep.” The waves of trouble come one after another, and he feels submerged. But even there, God has not left. “By day the LORD commands his steadfast love, and at night his song is with me.” In the midst of the flood, there is a song. The psalmist does not claim to feel better, but he affirms where hope lies.

He does not hide the hard question: “Why have you forgotten me?” Honest prayer includes honest questions. And he answers them not with explanations but with the refrain: “Hope in God.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink” (John 7:37), and he promised the woman at the well living water (John 4:10-14). He experienced forsakenness on the cross for our sake (Matthew 27:46). Revelation 7:17 promises that the Lamb “will guide them to springs of living water.” Peter calls us to hope in God through Christ (1 Peter 1:21). Jesus himself said, “My soul is very sorrowful” (Matthew 26:38).

STEP 6

Application

Preach to yourself today. Take the refrain, “Hope in God,” and speak it to your soul.

Remember a time of joyful worship, and let it feed your longing.

Bring your honest question, “Why?” to God. Do not stop at the question; add the hope.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what your soul thirsts for.
- Ask him to teach you to hope in him when you are cast down.
- Ask him for his steadfast love by day and song by night.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 49

“And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God.”

1 KINGS 18:39

DAY 338 · WEEK 49

Psalm 43

Send out your light and your truth

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 43. It is the second half of the poem you began yesterday. Notice how the psalmist asks for light and truth, and how he moves toward the altar of God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 43 has no title in the Hebrew, and many manuscripts join it with Psalm 42 as a single poem. It shares the same refrain. The first psalm described the longing, and this psalm makes the request. The psalmist is surrounded by deceitful people, and he asks God to vindicate him and bring him back to worship.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Vindicate me, O God, and defend my cause against an ungodly people” (v. 1).
2. “From the deceitful and unjust man deliver me!” (v. 1).
3. “For you are the God in whom I take refuge; why have you rejected me?” (v. 2).
4. “Why do I go about mourning because of the oppression of the enemy?” (v. 2).
5. “Send out your light and your truth; let them lead me; let them bring me to your holy hill and to your dwelling!” (v. 3).
6. “Then I will go to the altar of God, to God my exceeding joy” (v. 4).
7. “And I will praise you with the lyre, O God, my God” (v. 4).
8. “Why are you cast down, O my soul, and why are you in turmoil within me? Hope in God; for I shall again praise him, my salvation and my God” (v. 5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Where Psalm 42 was a lament, Psalm 43 is a petition. The psalmist asks God to be his advocate. He is in the middle of a case, and he wants God to judge between him and his enemies. He does not take revenge. He asks for vindication, for God to set things right.

Verse 2 repeats the question from Psalm 42:9: "Why have you rejected me?" The psalmist is honest about how it feels. He knows that God is his refuge, and yet he feels abandoned. The two statements sit side by side. This is not contradiction. It is the real experience of believers who have faith but not yet sight.

Verse 3 is the center of the poem: "Send out your light and your truth." The psalmist treats God's light and truth as if they were two messengers who could be dispatched to lead him. They are personified, almost like angels. Light shows the way, and truth keeps him from deception. He needs both. When surrounded by lies, he asks for truth. When in darkness, he asks for light.

Where do they lead? To God's holy hill, his dwelling place. The psalmist's goal is not just rescue but worship. He wants to return to the altar and to "God my exceeding joy." Literally, "the gladness of my joy." God himself is the source of the psalmist's deepest happiness. He wants to be where God is.

The refrain returns for a third time. It is almost stubborn. "Hope in God; for I shall again praise him." The "again" is important. The psalmist is confident that the dry time will end and that praise will return.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the light and truth that God sent. "I am the light of the world" (John 8:12) and "I am the way, and the truth, and the life" (John 14:6). "Grace and truth came through Jesus Christ" (John 1:17). Hebrews 10:19-22 shows that through Christ we have access to God's presence, the "altar" the psalmist longed for. Jesus is our advocate with the Father (1 John 2:1).

STEP 6

Application

Pray verse 3 for a specific situation: "Send out your light and your truth."

Ask God to lead you to his dwelling, to a deeper experience of worship.

Say the refrain aloud, "Hope in God," and add "for I shall again praise him."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to send out his light and truth to lead you.
- Tell him that he is your exceeding joy.
- Tell your soul to hope in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 49

"And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God."

1 KINGS 18:39

DAY 339 · WEEK 49

1 Kings 17:1-19:21

Elijah, drought, Zarephath, Carmel, Horeb

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 17:1-19:21. These are the great chapters about Elijah: the drought, the widow of Zarephath, the showdown on Mount Carmel, and the quiet voice on Mount Horeb. Read them slowly, and pay attention to what God does at each stage.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Under Ahab and Jezebel, Baal worship has been established as the official religion in Israel. Baal was a Canaanite storm and fertility god, credited with sending rain. Into this setting steps Elijah the Tishbite, a prophet from Gilead. His name means "my God is Yahweh." He announces a drought, and the confrontation is on: which God controls the rain?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "As the LORD, the God of Israel, lives, before whom I stand, there shall be neither dew nor rain these years, except by my word" (17:1).
2. The LORD sends Elijah to the brook Cherith, where ravens bring him bread and meat (17:2-6).
3. At Zarephath, a widow gives Elijah her last meal, and "the jar of flour was not spent, neither did the jug of oil become empty" (17:8-16).
4. Elijah raises the widow's son, and she says, "Now I know that you are a man of God, and that the word of the LORD in your mouth is truth" (17:17-24).
5. "How long will you go limping between two different opinions? If the LORD is God, follow him; but if Baal, then follow him" (18:21).

6. Baal's prophets cry out from morning to evening, but "there was no voice. No one answered" (18:26-29).
7. "Then the fire of the LORD fell and consumed the burnt offering"; the people said, "The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God" (18:38-39).
8. At Horeb, God is not in the wind, earthquake, or fire, but in "a low whisper" (19:11-12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The drought is a direct challenge to Baal. The god of the storm cannot bring rain, and the LORD controls the weather. But the first part of Elijah's ministry takes place away from the public eye. He hides at Cherith, fed by ravens, and then goes to Zarephath, in Sidon, the homeland of Jezebel. The God of Israel is caring for a foreign widow and her son, and showing that his power reaches beyond Israel. Jesus will point to this very story (Luke 4:25-26).

The showdown at Carmel is the center of the passage. Elijah does not ask the people for loyalty to God alone. He asks them to decide: "How long will you go limping between two opinions?" Divided loyalty is not neutrality. It is a form of unfaithfulness. The contest is simple. The god who answers by fire is God. Baal's prophets cry and cut themselves all day. Nothing happens. Elijah mocks them, "Cry aloud, for he is a god." Then he rebuilds the LORD's altar with twelve stones, representing all Israel, soaks it with water three times, and prays a short prayer. Fire falls. The people declare, "The LORD, he is God."

Then comes an odd turn. After the greatest victory of his life, Elijah runs in fear from Jezebel's threat. He sits under a broom tree and asks to die. "It is enough; now, O LORD, take my life." The prophet who stood boldly on Carmel is now exhausted, depressed, and alone. God's response is gentle. He lets Elijah sleep and sends an angel with food. The first thing God offers is rest and a meal.

At Horeb, the same mountain where Moses met God, Elijah expects power. Wind, earthquake, and fire pass, but the LORD is not in them. Then a low whisper. The God of fire is also the God of the quiet voice. And he tells Elijah that he is not alone: seven thousand in Israel have not bowed to Baal. He gives him work to do, including calling Elisha.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus cited the widow of Zarephath in his first sermon (Luke 4:25-26). John the Baptist came "in the spirit and power of Elijah" (Luke 1:17), and Jesus said Elijah had already come (Matthew 17:11-13). Jesus fed the five thousand, a greater miracle of provision. He raised a

widow's son at Nain (Luke 7:11-17). At the transfiguration, Elijah appeared with Moses to speak with Jesus (Luke 9:30). Romans 11:2-5 uses the story of the seven thousand to show that God always keeps a remnant.

STEP 6

Application

Where are you limping between two opinions? Make your decision today.

If you are exhausted after a hard season, remember that God first gave Elijah food and sleep.

Listen for the low whisper of God in the quiet today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from limping between two opinions.
- Tell him where you are weary, and ask him to feed and rest you.
- Listen for his whisper and tell him what you hear.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 49

"And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God."

1 KINGS 18:39

DAY 340 · WEEK 49

1 Kings 20:1-22:53

Ahab's wars; Naboth's vineyard; Jehoshaphat

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 103 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 20:1-22:53. Ahab's wars with Syria, the story of Naboth's vineyard, and the death of Ahab are told here. Notice the way God uses prophets to confront the king, and the key difference between the true prophet Micaiah and the 400 who tell the king what he wants to hear.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After Carmel, Ahab remains king, and the chapters that follow show him at war with Syria and in conflict with the prophets. The story of Naboth's vineyard is one of the most disturbing accounts of abuse of power in Scripture. The section ends with an alliance between Ahab and Jehoshaphat, the godly king of Judah, and a battle at Ramoth-gilead where Ahab dies.

STEP 3

Observation

1. A prophet tells Ahab that God will give him victory over the Syrians "that you may know that I am the LORD" (20:13).
2. The Syrians say, "The LORD is a god of the hills but he is not a god of the valleys," and God defeats them again (20:28).
3. Ahab spares Ben-hadad, and a prophet says, "Your life shall be for his life" (20:34-42).
4. Naboth refuses to sell his vineyard: "The LORD forbid that I should give you the inheritance of my fathers" (21:3).
5. Jezebel arranges false witnesses and has Naboth stoned (21:5-14).
6. Elijah confronts Ahab: "Have you killed and also taken possession?" (21:19).

7. Ahab humbles himself, and God delays the disaster (21:27-29).
8. The prophet Micaiah says, “As the LORD lives, what the LORD says to me, that I will speak” (22:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 20 shows God’s patience with Ahab. Twice he gives him victory over a stronger enemy, so that Ahab will know that God is the LORD. The Syrians’ belief that the LORD is a god of the hills only is corrected. His power is not limited by geography. Yet Ahab fails to follow through, making a treaty with a man God had devoted to destruction.

Chapter 21 shows what power does when it ignores God. Ahab wants a vineyard. Naboth refuses on principle: it is his family’s inheritance, given under the covenant law (Leviticus 25:23). Ahab goes home to sulk. Jezebel takes over, forges letters, arranges a show trial with false witnesses, and Naboth is killed. The scene mimics a legal process while committing murder. When Ahab comes to take the vineyard, Elijah is waiting. “Have you killed and also taken possession?” This is one of the great confrontations of the Bible. A prophet stands against a king to defend the rights of a poor man.

Naboth’s story shows that God cares about justice, property, and truth. The abuse of the weak by the powerful is not outside his concern. The prophets will return to this theme in Amos and Micah, which you will read later in this unit.

The most surprising detail is that Ahab humbles himself when he hears the judgment. He tears his clothes and fasts. And God sees it, and delays the disaster to the next generation. The mercy of God is wide. Even a wicked man’s partial repentance is noticed.

In chapter 22, Ahab asks 400 prophets whether to go to battle. They all say yes. Jehoshaphat asks, “Is there not here another prophet of the LORD?” Micaiah is the one prophet who says what God says, and it is bad news. He stands alone against the crowd. The story ends with Ahab disguised in battle, struck by a random arrow, and dying as the prophets said. The word of the LORD stands.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus, too, stood alone before a crowd and spoke the truth. He defended the vulnerable and confronted powerful men (Matthew 23). The false witnesses at Naboth’s trial recall the false witnesses against Jesus (Matthew 26:59-61). Jesus said, “Woe to you when all people speak well of you, for so their fathers did to the false prophets” (Luke 6:26). Hebrews 11:36-38 speaks of the faithful who suffered for the truth.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you are listening to the voices that tell you what you want to hear.

Think about someone who has less power than you. Are you protecting them?

Speak the truth in love this week, even when it is costly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he sees the poor and hears the cry of the wronged.

Ask him for the courage of Micaiah to speak what he says.

Ask him to keep you from the chorus of flatterers.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 49

"And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God."

1 KINGS 18:39

DAY 341 · WEEK 49

2 Kings 1:1-2:25

Elijah taken up; Elisha receives the mantle

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 1:1-2:25. Elijah's ministry ends in a whirlwind, and Elisha takes up his mantle. Notice the careful details about the crossing of the Jordan and the request for a double portion.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The book of 2 Kings begins where 1 Kings ended, with Ahab's death and his son Ahaziah on the throne. Elijah's final acts include a confrontation over consulting a foreign god. Then the narrative turns to the transition from Elijah to Elisha, one of the most dramatic passages in the Old Testament. The crossing of the Jordan recalls Joshua and the exodus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Ahaziah sends messengers to inquire of Baal-zebub, and Elijah says, "Is it because there is no God in Israel that you are going to inquire of Baal-zebub?" (1:3).
2. Fire falls from heaven on two companies of fifty, but the third captain pleads for his life (1:9-15).
3. Elijah and Elisha cross the Jordan on dry ground when Elijah strikes the water with his cloak (2:8).
4. Elisha says, "Please let there be a double portion of your spirit on me" (2:9).
5. "And behold, chariots of fire and horses of fire separated the two of them. And Elijah went up by a whirlwind into heaven" (2:11).
6. Elisha cries, "My father, my father! The chariots of Israel and its horsemen!" (2:12).

7. Elisha takes up Elijah's cloak and asks, "Where is the LORD, the God of Elijah?" and strikes the water, and it parts (2:13-14).

8. The sons of the prophets say, "The spirit of Elijah rests on Elisha" (2:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 1 shows once again the foolishness of seeking help from other gods. Ahaziah is ill and sends to Baal-zebub, the god of Ekron. The question Elijah asks is blunt: "Is it because there is no God in Israel?" It is a rebuke to all who treat the true God as one option among many. The fire episode is dramatic and shows the seriousness of opposing God's prophet. The third captain's humble approach is the one that finds mercy.

Chapter 2 is the high point. Elijah is about to be taken, and Elisha will not leave him. Three times Elijah tells him to stay behind, and three times Elisha refuses. His loyalty and persistence are remarkable. When Elijah asks what he can do for him, Elisha does not ask for wealth or safety. He asks for a double portion of Elijah's spirit, the share of the firstborn son. He wants to be Elijah's heir and to continue his ministry.

The departure of Elijah is one of two times in the Old Testament that someone is taken to heaven without dying (the other is Enoch). Chariots and horses of fire appear, a vision of the heavenly army. Elisha's cry, "My father, my father!" acknowledges Elijah as a spiritual father and as Israel's real defense. The chariots of Israel are not its armies but its prophets.

Then Elisha takes the cloak, steps to the Jordan, and asks the question that sums up the whole passage: "Where is the LORD, the God of Elijah?" The prophet is gone, but God remains. The waters part. Elisha is not Elijah, but the same God is with him.

The chapter ends with a hard episode: boys mock Elisha and are attacked by bears. This is not about baldness. It is about contempt for God's prophet, and the seriousness of mocking God's word.

STEP 5

Connection

John the Baptist came in the spirit and power of Elijah (Luke 1:17). Jesus ascended into heaven, taken up before the eyes of his disciples (Acts 1:9-11), and sent the Spirit on them. The "double portion" finds its fulfillment at Pentecost. Hebrews 2:2-4 warns against ignoring a greater salvation. Jesus crossed from death to life and opened the way for all his people.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you want a double portion of God's Spirit, and what you would do with it.

Practice Elisha's persistence in following a spiritual mentor.

When someone you depend on is taken from you, ask, "Where is the LORD, the God of Elijah?" and trust that he remains.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to give you a hunger for his Spirit.

Thank him that he remains when those who guide you are gone.

Ask him to keep you from mocking what he sends.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 49

"And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God."

1 KINGS 18:39

DAY 342 · WEEK 49

2 Kings 3:1-4:44

Moab defeated; Elisha's miracles begin

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 3:1-4:44. Elisha's ministry begins with the defeat of Moab and a series of miracles of provision and restoration. Look for how these miracles echo the work of Elijah and anticipate the work of Jesus.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Elisha begins his ministry under King Jehoram of Israel, son of Ahab. A coalition of Israel, Judah, and Edom marches against Moab and nearly dies of thirst. Elisha is called, and God provides. Chapter 4 follows with four miracles in the lives of ordinary people: a widow's oil, a Shunammite woman's son, a poisoned stew, and a feeding of one hundred men.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The three kings are without water, and Jehoshaphat asks, "Is there no prophet of the LORD here, through whom we may inquire of the LORD?" (3:11).
2. Elisha says, "You shall not see wind or rain, but that streambed shall be filled with water" (3:17).
3. The Moabite king sacrifices his son on the wall, and "there came great wrath against Israel" (3:27).
4. A widow cries, "Your servant my husband is dead… and the creditor has come to take my two children," and Elisha multiplies her oil (4:1-7).
5. A woman of Shunem builds a room for Elisha, and God gives her a son (4:8-17).
6. The boy dies, and the woman says, "It is well," and Elisha raises him (4:18-37).

7. Elisha purifies a poisoned stew: “Then bring flour... and there was no harm in the pot” (4:38-41).

8. He feeds a hundred men with twenty loaves, “For thus says the LORD, They shall eat and have some left” (4:42-44).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 3 shows God’s mercy to a flawed alliance. Jehoram is no friend of the LORD, but because of Jehoshaphat, Elisha speaks. The water arrives not by rain but by a miracle, and in the morning the sun on the water looks like blood to the Moabites. The victory is God’s gift. The ending is strange and grim: the king of Moab sacrifices his own son, and Israel withdraws. The chapter shows how dark pagan religion could be.

Chapter 4 turns to the ordinary lives of the poor. The widow is about to lose her sons to a creditor. She has only a jar of oil. Elisha tells her to borrow empty vessels, as many as she can, and the oil flows until all the jars are full. God’s provision is limited only by her faith and the number of jars. It is a picture of grace that meets need and overflows.

The Shunammite woman is a model of hospitality. She sees that Elisha is a holy man and builds a small room for him. When she receives a promise of a son, she is incredulous. And when the boy dies, she says, “It is well.” Her faith is mixed with grief, but she goes straight to the man of God. Elisha stretches himself over the boy and he lives. It is the first account of resurrection in the Old Testament after Elijah’s raising of the widow’s son.

The last two miracles are simple. Death in the pot is turned to food, and a small gift of bread feeds a hundred men with some left over. The theme is the same: in a land of famine and idolatry, God’s word brings life and provision. The “sons of the prophets” are fed because of the faithfulness of a few.

Elisha’s miracles are works of mercy. They are directed at the vulnerable. They show what kind of God the LORD is: one who sees the needs of the poor.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus did every one of these miracles on a larger scale. He fed the five thousand with five loaves and two fish, “and they all ate and were satisfied” (Luke 9:12-17). He raised a widow’s son (Luke 7:11-17), and Jairus’s daughter (Luke 8:49-56). He turned water into wine (John 2). He said, “I am the bread of life” (John 6:35). Elisha’s miracles point to the One who has power over death and hunger.

STEP 6

Application

Ask God to show you your “empty jars,” places where you need his provision. Bring them in faith.

Practice hospitality, as the Shunammite did. Whom can you welcome?

When you face a loss, say with the Shunammite, “It is well,” as an act of trust, even through grief.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what vessels in your life feel empty.
- Ask him to teach you hospitality.
- Thank him that you can say “It is well” in sorrow.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 49

“And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God.”

1 KINGS 18:39

DAY 343 · WEEK 49

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Kings 18:39 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God."

1 KINGS 18:39

REST

Meditation

This is the people's response on Mount Carmel after fire falls from heaven. It is a simple confession, repeated for emphasis, and it is the heart of what the prophets were sent to say.

"When all the people saw it." They had been standing on the fence. Elijah asked them how long they would go limping between two opinions, and they had said nothing. Now they see. God does not always answer prayer with fire from heaven, but when he acts, his people recognize it.

"They fell on their faces." This is the posture of worship and of surrender. It is not a casual nod of agreement. They are overwhelmed. They realize that they have been wrong.

"The LORD, he is God." This is the confession that Israel was made for. The Hebrew is emphatic: Yahweh, he is the God. It echoes the Shema: "The LORD our God, the LORD is one." And it echoes Elijah's own name, "My God is Yahweh." All of Elijah's mission is encapsulated

in this sentence.

"The LORD, he is God." The repetition is the people's way of saying it with their whole heart. They say it twice because they cannot say it enough.

In the days of the divided kingdom, the question was always, "Who is God?" Baal or the LORD? Money or the LORD? The king or the LORD? The same question faces us. This verse is an invitation to make the confession again. Not just once, but daily. The LORD, he is God. Christ is Lord (Philippians 2:11). Say it when you are tempted to serve something else.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed the divided kingdom into the age of Elijah and Elisha. You read Psalms 42 and 43, the cry of a soul thirsting for God, with the refrain "Hope in God." You saw Elijah announce the drought, be fed by ravens, and confront the prophets of Baal on Carmel, where fire fell and the people confessed, "The LORD, he is God." You saw the same prophet, exhausted and afraid, meet God in a low whisper at Horeb. You read the story of Naboth's vineyard, and the lone prophet Micaiah. You watched Elijah taken to heaven and Elisha take up the mantle, and you read the miracles of Elisha for widows, a Shunammite, and the hungry. The week taught that God is the one true God, that he cares for the weak, and that he speaks even in whispers.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Elijah moved from triumph on Carmel to despair under the broom tree. How does God's gentle care of him encourage you in a season of exhaustion?

Elisha's miracles of provision and resurrection point to Jesus, the bread of life and the conqueror of death. Which of these miracles speaks most to a need you have right now?

Naboth was wronged by the powerful, and God sent a prophet to defend him. Who in your world needs someone to speak up for them?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God that the LORD, he is God, and why you say it.

Thank him for answering by fire and speaking in a whisper.

Thank him for caring for the poor and grieving.

DAY 344 · WEEK 50

Psalm 44

We have not forgotten you, communal lament

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 44. This is a corporate lament, the prayer of a whole people who feel abandoned by God even though they have been faithful. Notice that the psalm does not confess a sin. Read it with those who suffer innocently.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 44 is a psalm of the sons of Korah. It reflects a time of national defeat: the army has been routed, the people scattered, and the nation mocked. We do not know the exact occasion. It fits any period of national humiliation, and it has been prayed by God's people in many centuries. Here, in the age of the divided kingdom, it gives voice to the faithful in a time of judgment.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O God, we have heard with our ears, our fathers have told us, what deeds you performed in their days" (v. 1).
2. "For not by their own sword did they win the land, nor did their own arm save them, but your right hand and your arm" (v. 3).
3. "In God we have boasted continually, and we will give thanks to your name forever" (v. 8).
4. "But you have rejected us and disgraced us and have not gone out with our armies" (v. 9).
5. "You have made us like sheep for slaughter and have scattered us among the nations" (v. 11).

6. “All this has come upon us, though we have not forgotten you, and we have not been false to your covenant” (v. 17).
7. “Yet for your sake we are killed all the day long; we are regarded as sheep to be slaughtered” (v. 22).
8. “Awake! Why are you sleeping, O Lord? Rouse yourself! Do not reject us forever!” (v. 23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with memory. The people recall what God did for their ancestors in the conquest. They know that victory was God’s gift, not their own achievement. This is the foundation of their confidence: God has acted before.

Then comes the shock of verse 9, marked by the word “But.” The God who gave them victory has now rejected them. The psalm describes the defeat in blunt terms. The army is routed. The people are sold for nothing. Neighbors mock. The psalmist feels deep shame.

The most striking feature is the claim of innocence. “All this has come upon us, though we have not forgotten you.” Unlike many laments, there is no confession of sin. The people say that they have been faithful. Whether this is a claim of perfection or a statement about their covenant loyalty in general, the psalm expresses the experience of suffering that is not explained by wrongdoing. The Bible allows for this. Not every hardship is a punishment. Sometimes the righteous suffer, and the psalm lets them say so.

The language of the closing verses is bold. “Awake! Why are you sleeping, O Lord?” It is not irreverence. It is the language of covenant. The people are saying, “You promised to be with us. Where are you?” They have no explanation, only an appeal: “Redeem us for the sake of your steadfast love.” The final plea rests on God’s character. It is not their merit but his covenant love that gives them hope.

Verse 22 is quoted by Paul in Romans 8:36, and he applies it to the experience of believers: “For your sake we are killed all the day long.” He then declares, “In all these things we are more than conquerors through him who loved us.” The psalm’s question is answered in Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes verse 22 in Romans 8:36 and answers the psalm’s cry with the assurance that nothing can separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus (Romans 8:37-39). Jesus is the Lamb led to slaughter (Isaiah 53:7; Acts 8:32). 2 Corinthians 4:8-11 describes the suffering of

the faithful. Jesus himself cried, “Why have you forsaken me?” (Matthew 27:46), taking the experience of abandonment on himself.

STEP 6

Application

If you are suffering though you have been faithful, pray this psalm. God hears the cry that does not explain.

Recall what God has done for your ancestors in faith, and tell it to someone younger.

Read Romans 8:31-39 alongside this psalm and hold both.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what he has done in days of old that you cling to.
- Ask him to rise up and help.
- Thank him that nothing can separate you from his love.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 50

“Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them.”

2 KINGS 6:16

DAY 345 · WEEK 50

Psalm 60

O God, you have rejected us

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 60. David prays after a military setback and ends with confidence in God. Notice the movement from complaint to promise to prayer.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The title of Psalm 60 places it in a time when David fought Aram and Edom, and Joab struck down 12,000 Edomites in the Valley of Salt (see 2 Samuel 8). It reflects an initial defeat before the victory. It follows Psalm 44 as a second corporate lament, but ends with more resolve. It is a prayer of a king and nation that have been shaken.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O God, you have rejected us, broken our defenses; you have been angry; oh, restore us" (v. 1).
2. "You have made the land to quake; you have torn it open; repair its breaches, for it totters" (v. 2).
3. "You have made your people see hard things; you have given us wine to drink that made us stagger" (v. 3).
4. "You have set up a banner for those who fear you, that they may flee to it from the bow" (v. 4).
5. "That your beloved ones may be delivered, give salvation by your right hand and answer us!" (v. 5).
6. "God has spoken in his holiness: With exultation I will divide up Shechem" (v. 6).
7. "Oh grant us help against the foe, for vain is the salvation of man!" (v. 11).

8 “With God we shall do valiantly; it is he who will tread down our foes” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with the same bewildering confession as Psalm 44: God has rejected us. But here, the language is of an earthquake. The land has cracked open. The structure of national life is shaking. The psalmist does not blame bad luck or strategy. He sees God’s hand in it. This may seem harsh, but it is also a comfort: if God broke it, God can repair it. “Repair its breaches, for it totters.” The one who allowed the crack is the only one who can mend it.

The image of the wine that makes people stagger is strong. God has made his people drink a cup of reeling. They have “seen hard things.” The Bible does not shy away from the fact that God’s people sometimes go through suffering that disorients them.

Yet verse 4 offers a turn: “You have set up a banner for those who fear you.” A banner is a rallying point in battle. God provides a place to gather. In the midst of defeat, there is a standard to flee to. For those who fear him, he is both the one who shakes and the one who shelters.

Then, in verses 6 to 8, God speaks. His voice cuts through the confusion. He claims Shechem, Succoth, Gilead, Manasseh, Ephraim, and Judah as his. Moab, Edom, and Philistia are described as his washbasin, his sandal, and his subjects. Everything belongs to him. The promise of God’s word is the foundation of the king’s confidence.

The final prayer is one of the best in the Bible for a time of need: “Oh grant us help against the foe, for vain is the salvation of man!” Human help is empty. “With God we shall do valiantly.” The psalm ends in confidence, not because circumstances changed, but because the speaker has remembered who God is.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” (Romans 8:31). Jesus is the banner raised for the nations (Isaiah 11:10; John 12:32). 2 Corinthians 12:9-10 shows strength made perfect in weakness. Psalm 108:6-13 repeats this psalm’s final section. 1 Corinthians 15:57: “Thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.”

STEP 6

Application

If something in your life feels like an earthquake, ask God to repair the breach.

Look for the “banner” God has set up for you, whether it is his word, his church, or his promise.

Pray verse 12 today: “With God we shall do valiantly.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to repair what has been shaken in your life.
- Admit that human help is vain, and ask for his.
- Thank him that with him we shall do valiantly.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 50

“Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them.”

2 KINGS 6:16

DAY 346 · WEEK 50

2 Kings 5:1-6:33

Naaman healed; Gehazi's greed; the Syrian siege

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 5:1-6:33. Naaman the Syrian is healed of leprosy, Gehazi's greed is judged, and Elisha is surrounded by an army and sees a greater one. Read the story of Naaman as a picture of grace that humbles.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Elisha's ministry extends to foreigners. Naaman is a commander of the Syrian army, Israel's enemy, and a leper. Through the witness of a captured Israelite girl, he comes to the prophet. These chapters include one of the Bible's best stories of grace, followed by a sad story of greed, and the account of the Syrian siege of Samaria.

STEP 3

Observation

1. A little Israelite girl says to Naaman's wife, "Would that my lord were with the prophet who is in Samaria! He would cure him of his leprosy" (5:3).
2. Elisha sends a messenger: "Go and wash in the Jordan seven times, and your flesh shall be restored" (5:10).
3. Naaman is angry: "Behold, I thought that he would surely come out to me" (5:11).
4. His servants say, "If the prophet had commanded you to do some great thing, would you not have done it?" (5:13).
5. "His flesh was restored like the flesh of a little child, and he was clean" (5:14).
6. Naaman says, "Behold, I know that there is no God in all the earth but in Israel" (5:15).
7. Gehazi takes a gift Elisha refused, and Naaman's leprosy clings to him (5:20-27).
8. "Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them" (6:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The story begins with a nameless girl. She is a captive and a servant, with every reason to be bitter. Yet she wishes her master's health and points him to the prophet. A small voice of faith makes a large difference. God uses the unnoticed.

Naaman comes with horses, chariots, silver, gold, and a letter from a king. He expects a spectacle. Elisha does not even come out. He sends a messenger with a plain instruction: wash in the Jordan. Naaman is furious. The muddy Jordan seems beneath him. He wanted to be healed on his own terms, in a way that honored his status. It is a picture of pride that resists grace. His servants help him see sense: "If he had commanded you to do some great thing, would you not have done it? How much more, when he says to you, Wash, and be clean?" The simplicity of the remedy was the offense.

When he humbles himself and obeys, he is healed and his skin becomes like a child's. He confesses the LORD as the only God. It is a conversion. He asks to take two mule-loads of earth, so that he can worship the LORD in Syria.

The contrast with Gehazi is sharp. Gehazi, who has been with the prophet and seen miracles, sees an opportunity to profit from grace. He lies to get the gift. The leprosy of Naaman passes to him. The outsider is cleansed, and the insider is judged. Proximity to God's work is no substitute for faith.

Chapter 6 gives a different scene. The Syrian army surrounds Elisha's city. His servant is terrified. Elisha prays, and the servant's eyes are opened to see the hills full of horses and chariots of fire. The unseen world is real. And Elisha's unusual response to the captured Syrian army is to feed them and send them home. "And the Syrians no more came on raids." Kindness did what swords could not.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus used Naaman's story in his sermon at Nazareth (Luke 4:27), pointing out that God's mercy reaches the Gentiles. Baptism is a washing that seems simple but is a sign of cleansing by grace (Titus 3:5). Romans 12:20-21 says to feed your enemy and overcome evil with good. Jesus told his disciples, "Do not be afraid, little flock" (Luke 12:32), and Revelation 5:11 shows the heavenly host surrounding the throne. 1 Timothy 6:10 warns of the love of money, as seen in Gehazi.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where pride keeps you from receiving grace in a simple form.

Think about the “little girl” in your life who points you to God. Thank them.

Pray for the eyes of your heart to be opened, as Elisha prayed for his servant.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to humble your pride so that you can receive his grace in the simple way he gives it.

Thank him for the little ones who point to him.

Ask him to open your eyes to see his armies around you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 50

“Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them.”

2 KINGS 6:16

DAY 347 · WEEK 50

2 Kings 7:1-8:29

The siege lifted; Elisha's prophecies fulfilled

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 7:1-8:29. The siege of Samaria is lifted by four lepers, and Elisha's prophecies are fulfilled. Notice how God's word comes true in unexpected ways, and the quiet sadness of Elisha's meeting with Hazael.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Samaria is under siege by the Syrians, and the famine is so severe that people are eating the unthinkable. In the middle of the despair, Elisha announces that by tomorrow, food will be cheap. The chapter that follows tells how God does it. In chapter 8, the story widens to include the Shunammite woman's land and the beginning of Hazael's reign in Syria.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Elisha says, "Hear the word of the LORD: thus says the LORD, Tomorrow about this time a seah of fine flour shall be sold for a shekel" (7:1).
2. The king's officer says, "If the LORD himself should make windows in heaven, could this thing be?" (7:2).
3. Four lepers at the gate say, "Why are we sitting here until we die?" (7:3).
4. They find the Syrian camp abandoned: the LORD had made the army hear the sound of chariots and horses (7:6-7).
5. "We are not doing right. This day is a day of good news. If we are silent and wait until the morning light, punishment will overtake us. Now therefore come, let us go and tell" (7:9).
6. "And the people went out and plundered the camp of the Syrians" (7:16).

7. The officer who doubted is trampled at the gate and dies (7:17-20).
8. Elisha weeps before Hazael: “I know the evil that you will do to the people of Israel” (8:11-12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter turns on a surprising set of heroes. Four lepers, outcasts and untouchables, sitting outside the city gate, are the ones God uses to deliver Samaria. They have nothing to lose. They reason that if they stay, they die, and if they go to the Syrian camp, they may live. When they find the camp empty and full of food, they eat and hide treasure. Then their conscience speaks: “We are not doing right. This day is a day of good news.” They go to tell the city.

The scene is a picture of evangelism. The lepers did not earn the abundance. They were simply the first to discover it. Having received, they felt compelled to share. “This day is a day of good news.” The Greek word for gospel is “good news.” The image of beggars telling other beggars where to find bread is one that has been used to describe the gospel.

God’s word is fulfilled to the letter. The price of flour drops overnight, exactly as Elisha said. And the officer who scoffed, “Could this thing be?” sees it but does not eat of it. He is trampled in the rush at the gate. The word of the LORD does not fail, and unbelief has a cost.

In chapter 8, the story of the Shunammite’s land shows God’s providence in small things. She returns from famine exactly when the king is hearing Gehazi tell her story, and her land is restored. Timing is not an accident.

The meeting with Hazael is sobering. Elisha weeps when he sees what Hazael will do to Israel. Hazael, who calls himself a dog, will become a brutal king. Elisha does not rejoice in judgment. The prophet weeps over what God shows him. And the chapter ends with the continuing decline of Judah, which has now joined itself to Ahab’s family by marriage.

STEP 5

Connection

The four lepers’ discovery is a picture of the gospel: poor, outcast people finding a feast and telling others. Jesus said, “Freely you have received; freely give” (Matthew 10:8). Jesus healed lepers (Luke 17:11-19) and sent his disciples to proclaim the good news. Elisha’s tears over Israel recall Jesus’ tears over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41). Hebrews 4:2 warns that the message did not benefit those who did not share the faith.

STEP 6

Application

Think of someone who needs to hear good news. Tell them today.

Examine yourself for unbelief like the officer's, a "could this thing be?" attitude toward God's word.

Weep over what grieves God, as Elisha did over Israel.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for good news for the poor, and ask him to make you someone who cannot keep it to yourself.

Confess where his word has met your unbelief.

Tell him one person to share it with.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 50

"Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them."

2 KINGS 6:16

DAY 348 · WEEK 50

2 Kings 9:1-10:36

Jehu's bloody reform, judgment on Ahab's house

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 9:1-10:36. Jehu is anointed to destroy the house of Ahab. This is one of the most violent sections of the Bible. Read it as God's judgment on a house that had murdered Naboth and the prophets, and notice what Jehu fails to do.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

A young prophet sent by Elisha anoints Jehu, a commander in the army, as king of Israel. His mission is to carry out the judgment announced by Elijah on the house of Ahab, which had led Israel into Baal worship and shed innocent blood. The story is fast, bloody, and sobering. It shows both the seriousness of God's judgment and the limits of human zeal.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Thus says the LORD, the God of Israel, I anoint you king over the people of the LORD, over Israel" (9:6).
2. "You shall strike down the house of Ahab your master, that I may avenge on Jezebel the blood of my servants the prophets" (9:7).
3. Jehu says to Joram, "What peace can there be, so long as the whorings and the sorceries of your mother Jezebel are so many?" (9:22).
4. Jezebel is thrown from her window, and the dogs eat her, as Elijah had said (9:30-37).
5. Jehu has all seventy sons of Ahab killed (10:1-11).
6. Jehu says to Jehonadab, "Come with me, and see my zeal for the LORD" (10:16).
7. Jehu tricks the worshipers of Baal into the temple and kills them, and "Jehu wiped out Baal from Israel" (10:18-28).

8 “But Jehu was not careful to walk in the law of the LORD, the God of Israel, with all his heart. He did not turn from the sins of Jeroboam” (10:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is a hard story to read. It is full of violence, and it is not easy to feel comfortable with it. The first thing to see is the context. Ahab’s house had killed Naboth, killed prophets, led the nation into idolatry, and ignored every warning. Elijah had announced judgment years before, and God had delayed because of Ahab’s humility. Now the delay is over. The word of the LORD is fulfilled to the letter: Jezebel is eaten by dogs, Ahab’s sons are killed, and Baal worship is purged.

The Bible does not present these events as a model for how believers should behave today. The church does not wield the sword. It is a record of God’s judgment against a specific house at a specific time, in the period of the old covenant, when Israel was a nation-state under God’s law.

The second thing to see is the flaw in Jehu. He is zealous, but his zeal is partial. He destroys Baal, but he does not turn from the golden calves of Jeroboam. He is efficient, but he also kills beyond what God commanded, and the prophet Hosea later criticizes the “blood of Jezreel” (Hosea 1:4). He says, “See my zeal for the LORD,” but he is also proud of it. Zeal without a whole heart is dangerous. Jehu cleans out one idol but keeps the other, and he does not love God with all his heart.

The summary verdict is one of the saddest in Kings: “Jehu was not careful to walk in the law of the LORD with all his heart.” God rewards his obedience with four generations of kings, but the decline continues. Partial reform is not enough.

The scene reminds us that God’s judgment is real. He does not overlook innocent blood. The judgment of Jezebel is the downfall of one who had killed prophets. And the passage invites us to examine whether our own obedience is whole-hearted.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 2:20 uses Jezebel as a symbol for false teaching in the church. Jesus is the king who will judge with righteousness, but who first took judgment on himself. Romans 12:19 reminds believers that vengeance belongs to God. Jesus rebuked James and John for wanting to call down fire (Luke 9:54-55). Matthew 22:37 calls us to love the LORD with all our heart, soul, and mind, the wholeheartedness Jehu lacked.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you have removed from your life in the name of faith and what you have kept.

Examine whether your zeal is for God's glory or for your own reputation.

Thank God that judgment fell on Christ, so that mercy can reach even the worst sinner.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he is just and does not forget innocent blood.
- Ask him for a whole heart, not partial reform.
- Ask him to keep your zeal from pride.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 50

"Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them."

2 KINGS 6:16

DAY 349 · WEEK 50

2 Kings 11:1-13:25

Athaliah; Joash; Jehoahaz

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 86 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 11:1-13:25. Athaliah tries to destroy the line of David, and a child king is hidden and crowned. Watch how God preserves the Davidic line, and read the story of Elisha's death.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In Judah, Ahaziah is killed by Jehu, and his mother Athaliah, the daughter of Ahab, seizes power by murdering the royal family. The Davidic line seems to be extinguished. In the north, the successors of Jehu rule under Syrian pressure. The section ends with the death of Elisha and a note about God's covenant faithfulness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When Athaliah the mother of Ahaziah saw that her son was dead, she arose and destroyed all the royal family" (11:1).
2. Jehosheba, Ahaziah's sister, takes baby Joash and hides him in the house of the LORD for six years (11:2-3).
3. The priest Jehoiada brings out the king's son, puts the crown on him, and anoints him, and they shout, "Long live the king!" (11:12).
4. "Then Jehoiada made a covenant between the LORD and the king and people, that they should be the LORD's people" (11:17).
5. The temple of Baal is torn down (11:18).
6. "And Jehoash did what was right in the eyes of the LORD all his days, because Jehoiada the priest instructed him" (12:2).

7. Jehoahaz seeks the LORD's favor, "and the LORD listened to him, for he saw the oppression of Israel" (13:4).

8. The LORD "was gracious to them and had compassion on them… because of his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob" (13:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Athaliah's rise is one of the darkest moments for Judah. She kills her own grandchildren to take the throne. The line of David, through which the promised Messiah is to come, is almost wiped out. It looks as though the covenant of 2 Samuel 7 has failed. But a woman named Jehosheba takes one baby, Joash, and hides him in the temple. For six years, while a murderous queen rules in Jerusalem, the hope of the world sleeps in a room in God's house.

It is a quiet picture of providence. God keeps his promises through the courage of ordinary people, a princess, a priest, a nurse. And in the seventh year, Jehoiada brings Joash out, surrounded by guards, and crowns him. The people clap their hands and shout, "Long live the king!" Athaliah, hearing the noise, cries "Treason!" and is put to death. The covenant is renewed: the king, the people, and the LORD.

Joash begins well. He repairs the temple, collecting money for the work, and the workers deal honestly. But the text says he did right "all his days, because Jehoiada the priest instructed him." It hints at a faith that depended on his mentor. We learn in 2 Chronicles that after Jehoiada's death, Joash drifted into idolatry and even killed Jehoiada's son. Borrowed faith is fragile.

In the north, the picture is grim. Syria oppresses Israel, and the kings continue in Jeroboam's sin. Yet there is a flash of mercy: Jehoahaz seeks the LORD, and God gives a deliverer. And the last verses of the section give the reason: God has compassion "because of his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob." It is grace that keeps Israel, not merit.

Elisha dies, and even in death his bones bring life: a dead man thrown into his tomb touches the bones and revives. God's power is not limited by death.

STEP 5

Connection

Herod would later try to kill the baby of David's line (Matthew 2:16), echoing Athaliah. God protected Jesus, as he protected Joash. Jesus is the true king hidden for a time who will be fully revealed. Revelation 12 shows the dragon trying to devour the child. Romans 11:28-29 says God's calling is irrevocable. The touch of Elisha's bones points to the resurrection life that flows from Christ (1 Corinthians 15:20).

STEP 6

Application

Think about the quiet acts of faithfulness, like Jehosheba's, that God uses to keep his promises. Is there one you can do?

Ask whether your faith depends on another person's influence. How can you make it your own?

Thank God for the covenant that keeps his people, even when they fail.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for hidden acts of courage that preserved his promises.

Ask him to make your faith your own.

Ask him to be gracious to his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 50

"Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them."

2 KINGS 6:16

DAY 350 · WEEK 50

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Kings 6:16 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them."

2 KINGS 6:16

REST

Meditation

Elisha says these words to his terrified servant, who has just woken up to find an enemy army surrounding the city. They are among the most comforting words in the Old Testament.

"Do not fear." This is one of the most common commands in the Bible. It is not a shallow instruction to stop feeling afraid. It comes with a reason. The servant had every reason to be afraid. The army was real. The danger was real. But the command rests on something he could not yet see.

"For those who are with us." Elisha says "us." He includes himself and his servant, and he points to a company that has not been introduced. Throughout Scripture, God's people are surrounded by unseen allies. Angels minister to the heirs of salvation (Hebrews 1:14). The host of heaven is real.

“Are more than those who are with them.” It is a statement of comparison. The enemy has numbers, but the people of God have more. It is not a promise that nothing bad will happen, but that, in the end, no enemy can overpower the LORD’s side.

Then Elisha prays, “O LORD, please open his eyes that he may see.” The servant looks again, and the hills are full of horses and chariots of fire. Nothing in the situation changed except the servant’s sight. Faith is not pretending the army isn’t there. It is seeing that there is something greater.

For the Christian, the greater presence is the LORD himself. “If God is for us, who can be against us?” (Romans 8:31). “He who is in you is greater than he who is in the world” (1 John 4:4). When you feel surrounded, ask God to open your eyes.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the healing of Naaman and the greed of Gehazi, the siege of Samaria lifted by four lepers, and Elisha’s vision of the chariots of fire. You read Psalms 44 and 60, the laments of a people who feel rejected by God, and the confidence that vain is the salvation of man. You saw the fall of the house of Ahab at the hand of Jehu, whose zeal was partial, and the near end of David’s line under Athaliah, thwarted by Jehosheba and Jehoiada. And you saw that God keeps his people for the sake of his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. The week taught that God uses the small and the outcast, that unbelief is costly, and that God preserves his promises through hidden faithfulness.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Naaman nearly missed his healing because the remedy seemed too simple. Where are you tempted to resist grace because it comes in a form you did not expect?

God hid the line of David in the temple for six years. How does that encourage you when God’s promises seem hidden or delayed? How does Christ, the true son of David, fulfill them?

The four lepers said, “This day is a day of good news,” and told others. Who needs to hear good news from you this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to open your eyes to see those who are with you.

Thank him for his covenant faithfulness.

Rest in Jesus, the true son of David.

DAY 351 · WEEK 51

Psalm 50

I do not rebuke you for sacrifices

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 50. You read this psalm in Unit 6. This time read it as a prophet's sermon, with the books of Kings in mind, and ask what God is saying to a people that went through the motions of religion but lived in injustice.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 50 is a psalm of Asaph, the temple musician. It presents God as a judge who summons his people to court. You first read it in Unit 6 as part of the story of worship. Here, in the age of the prophets, it takes on a different weight. This is exactly the charge that Amos, Hosea, and Micah will bring: sacrifices without obedience, religion without righteousness. Hosea 6:6, the anchor verse of this unit, could be a summary of the psalm.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The Mighty One, God the LORD, speaks and summons the earth from the rising of the sun to its setting" (v. 1).
2. "Out of Zion, the perfection of beauty, God shines forth" (v. 2).
3. "Hear, O my people, and I will speak, O Israel, I will testify against you" (v. 7).
4. "I do not rebuke you for your sacrifices; your burnt offerings are continually before me" (v. 8).
5. "For every beast of the forest is mine, the cattle on a thousand hills" (v. 10).
6. "If I were hungry, I would not tell you, for the world and its fullness are mine" (v. 12).
7. "Offer to God a sacrifice of thanksgiving, and perform your vows to the Most High, and call on me in the day of trouble; I will deliver you, and you shall glorify me" (vv. 14-15).

8 “These things you have done, and I have been silent; you thought that I was one like yourself” (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The scene is a courtroom, and God is both judge and witness. He summons the whole earth to listen, but the case is against his own people. The covenant people are on trial. This is the language of the prophets: God has a case against Israel.

The surprising part is the charge. God does not say, “You have failed to offer sacrifices.” He says, “I do not rebuke you for your sacrifices.” They have kept the rituals. The problem is that they think the rituals are what God needs. He answers with one of the Bible’s great statements of divine self-sufficiency: “If I were hungry, I would not tell you, for the world and its fullness are mine.” God does not depend on offerings. He owns every animal. To treat sacrifice as a way of feeding or bribing God is to misunderstand who he is.

What he wants is thanksgiving, vows kept, and prayer: “Offer to God a sacrifice of thanksgiving.” The real sacrifice is a heart that gives thanks. The relationship is not transactional. “Call on me in the day of trouble; I will deliver you, and you shall glorify me.” He is the giver, and we are the receivers. Our part is gratitude and trust.

The second half of the psalm turns on the wicked, those who recite God’s statutes but hate discipline. They steal, commit adultery, and slander, while keeping up the appearance of religion. They thought God’s silence meant approval: “You thought that I was one like yourself.” The great danger of religious hypocrisy is the assumption that God is like us, that he overlooks what we overlook.

The psalm ends with a warning and a promise. “Mark this, then, you who forget God, lest I tear you apart.” But “the one who offers thanksgiving as his sacrifice glorifies me; to one who orders his way rightly I will show the salvation of God.”

STEP 5

Connection

Hosea 6:6, which Jesus quotes in Matthew 9:13 and 12:7, says, “I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice.” Hebrews 13:15 says, “Through him then let us continually offer up a sacrifice of praise to God.” Acts 17:24-25 says that God is not served by human hands as though he needed anything. Jesus confronted those who honored God with their lips while their hearts were far from him (Matthew 15:8).

STEP 6

Application

Ask if you ever treat your religious activity as a way of earning God's favor.

Offer a sacrifice of thanksgiving today: name five things you are grateful for.

Examine whether any part of your life is hidden behind religious appearance.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that you can offer him a sacrifice of thanksgiving.
- Ask him to keep you from hypocrisy.
- Call on him in your day of trouble.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 51

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

AMOS 5:24

DAY 352 · WEEK 51

Psalm 52; Psalm 53

The boastful and the fool

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 52 and Psalm 53. The first is a psalm about a powerful, boastful man who is destroyed. The second is a near twin of Psalm 14, with the fool who says there is no God. Notice the contrast with the green olive tree.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 52 has the title "when Doeg the Edomite, came and told Saul, David has come to the house of Ahimelech." You read that story in Unit 9 (1 Samuel 22). Psalm 53 is a variation of Psalm 14, which you read earlier. Both psalms are by David, and they deal with the arrogance of evil and the fate of those who reject God. Together they fit a unit about a nation that forgot God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Why do you boast of evil, O mighty man? The steadfast love of God endures all the day" (52:1).
2. "Your tongue plots destruction, like a sharp razor, you worker of deceit" (52:2).
3. "You love evil more than good, and lying more than speaking what is right" (52:3).
4. "But God will break you down forever; he will snatch and tear you from your tent" (52:5).
5. "See the man who would not make God his refuge, but trusted in the abundance of his riches" (52:7).
6. "But I am like a green olive tree in the house of God. I trust in the steadfast love of God forever and ever" (52:8).

7. “The fool says in his heart, There is no God” (53:1).
8. “Oh that salvation for Israel would come out of Zion! When God restores the fortunes of his people, let Jacob rejoice, let Israel be glad” (53:6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 52 addresses Doeg directly, a man who used his power and his tongue to destroy the priests of Nob. David asks the question that exposes all boasting in evil: “Why do you boast?” The wicked man has power, but he does not have God’s steadfast love, which “endures all the day.” Evil has a limited life. The psalm describes a tongue like a razor, a man who loves lies, a man who trusts in riches. And it declares that God will break him down.

The central image is the contrast. The wicked man will be uprooted from his tent and from the land of the living. David, by contrast, is “like a green olive tree in the house of God.” An olive tree is long-lived and fruitful. It is planted in God’s house, in the place of his presence. The wicked man is torn out. The righteous man is rooted. The difference lies in where each puts his trust: in riches, or in “the steadfast love of God forever and ever.”

The psalm ends with thanksgiving. David says he will thank God forever for what he has done, and “wait for your name, for it is good.” He does not take revenge. He waits.

Psalm 53 is almost the same as Psalm 14, with small changes, and the repetition makes a point. The human heart’s tendency to say, “There is no God,” is not an occasional problem. It is universal. “They have all fallen away; together they have become corrupt; there is none who does good, not even one.” The Psalter wants us to hear this twice, so that we do not forget how deep the problem is.

Verse 5 adds a unique line: “There they were in great terror, where there was no terror, for God scatters the bones of him who encamps against you.” God defeats those who oppose his people, sometimes by simply causing fear. And again the psalm ends with the prayer for salvation to come out of Zion.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the root and the vine in whom we are planted (John 15:5). Psalm 1 and Jeremiah 17:7-8 echo the image of the tree. Paul quotes Psalm 14 and 53 in Romans 3:10-12 to prove that all are sinners, and he points to Christ as the answer (Romans 3:21-26). 1 Timothy 6:17 warns the rich not to trust in uncertain riches. Salvation did come out of Zion in Jesus (Romans 11:26).

STEP 6

Application

Name something you boast in. Bring it to God and ask for humility.

Thank God that you are planted in his house like an olive tree.

Pray, “Oh that salvation would come out of Zion,” for someone who does not yet know Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from boasting in evil or trusting in riches.
- Ask him to plant you like an olive tree in his house.
- Confess where you have lived as though there is no God.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 51

“But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream.”

AMOS 5:24

DAY 353 · WEEK 51

2 Kings 14:1-15:38

Jeroboam II's prosperity; the northern kingdom's final decades

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 14:1-15:38. These chapters trace the final decades of the northern kingdom, with Jeroboam II's prosperity and the rapid succession of kings after him. Notice the mixture of God's mercy and judgment.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In the first half of the 700s BC, Israel and Judah enjoy a period of prosperity and expansion. Jeroboam II of Israel reigns for forty-one years, and Uzziah (Azariah) in Judah for fifty-two. This is the world of Amos and Hosea, whom you will read next. After Jeroboam II, Israel collapses quickly, with six kings in about thirty years, and the Assyrian empire begins to take its land.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Amaziah of Judah does right "yet not like David his father" and wins a victory over Edom but is defeated by Jehoash of Israel (14:3, 7-14).
2. Jeroboam II "did what was evil in the sight of the LORD" (14:24).
3. "He restored the border of Israel from Lebo-hamath as far as the Sea of the Arabah, according to the word of the LORD… which he spoke by his servant Jonah the son of Amittai" (14:25).
4. "For the LORD saw that the affliction of Israel was very bitter… But the LORD had not said that he would blot out the name of Israel from under heaven, so he saved them by the hand of Jeroboam" (14:26-27).
5. Azariah (Uzziah) reigns fifty-two years, and "the LORD touched the king, so that he was a leper to the day of his death" (15:5).

6. Zechariah, Shallum, Menahem, Pekahiah, and Pekah each reign briefly, with murders and coups (15:8-31).
7. Tiglath-pileser, king of Assyria, takes cities and carries people captive (15:19, 29).
8. Jotham of Judah "did what was right… only the high places were not removed" (15:34-35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jeroboam II's reign is a paradox. By outward measures, it is the best of Israel's northern kings: territorial expansion, wealth, and stability. But the verdict is the same: "He did what was evil." The reason for his success is that God saw the bitter affliction of Israel and had compassion. The prosperity is mercy, not approval. This is a striking reminder that material success is not a sign of God's favor. Israel is flourishing and also rotting. Amos will describe the injustice beneath the prosperity.

Notice the mention of Jonah son of Amittai. The prophet Jonah, whose story you will read in this unit, lived in this time. He delivered a word of hope for Israel's borders. That same man will be sent to preach to Nineveh, Israel's future conqueror.

After Jeroboam II's death, the collapse is quick. The text lists king after king, each murdered by his successor or soon deposed. It is a picture of a nation that has no foundation. Within about thirty years, Assyria will take the land. The speed shows the rottenness of the kingdom.

In Judah, the picture is more stable. Uzziah reigns fifty-two years, and Jotham is faithful. But even the good kings leave the high places. The pattern of partial obedience continues. And Uzziah's leprosy is mentioned briefly here; 2 Chronicles 26 tells us it came when he proudly entered the temple. Pride undoes even the strong.

The chapters prepare the way for the prophets. The nation's outward success covers its decay. The rich oppress the poor. Worship goes on while justice is neglected. The coming words of Amos and Hosea will strip off the surface and show what is underneath.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, "Why do you call me Lord, Lord, and not do what I tell you?" (Luke 6:46). He warned that wealth can blind us (Mark 10:23-25). The mention of Jonah anticipates Jesus' sign of Jonah (Matthew 12:39-41). Revelation 3:17 describes a church that says, "I am rich… I need nothing," and does not know it is wretched. Hebrews 3:13 warns of the deceitfulness of sin.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your comfort or success has made you less attentive to God.

Think of a time when God showed mercy that you did not deserve. Thank him.

Pray for the leaders of your nation to seek the LORD in their prosperity.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you from mistaking comfort for his approval.

Ask him to strip away surface religion in you.

Thank him for seeing the affliction of Israel and showing mercy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 51

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

AMOS 5:24

DAY 354 · WEEK 51

Amos 1:1-2:16

Judgment on the nations and Israel

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Amos 1:1-2:16. Amos, a shepherd from Judah, announces God's judgment on the nations around Israel and then, to the shock of his hearers, on Israel itself. Notice the pattern: "For three transgressions... and for four."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Amos prophesied around 760 BC, during the reign of Jeroboam II, "two years before the earthquake." He was not a professional prophet. He was a herdsman and dresser of sycamore figs from Tekoa in Judah, sent north to Israel. His message is one of the sharpest in the Bible: God demands justice, and ritual without righteousness is worthless. The book opens with a series of oracles on the surrounding nations, a pattern that draws Israel in.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The words of Amos, who was among the shepherds of Tekoa" (1:1).
2. "The LORD roars from Zion and utters his voice from Jerusalem" (1:2).
3. "For three transgressions of Damascus, and for four, I will not revoke the punishment" (1:3).
4. The same formula is repeated for Gaza, Tyre, Edom, Ammon, and Moab (1:6-2:3).
5. For Judah: "because they have rejected the law of the LORD, and have not kept his statutes" (2:4).
6. For Israel: "because they sell the righteous for silver, and the needy for a pair of sandals" (2:6).

7. “They trample the head of the poor into the dust of the earth and turn aside the way of the afflicted” (2:7).

8. “Also it was I who brought you up out of the land of Egypt” (2:10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Amos begins like a preacher drawing a crowd. He starts with Israel’s enemies: Damascus, Gaza, Tyre, Edom, Ammon, Moab. His listeners would nod. These nations are guilty of brutality: threshing Gilead with iron sledges, selling whole communities as slaves, tearing open pregnant women, burning the bones of a king. God is a judge of the nations. They are accountable even though they do not have the law of Moses. There is a moral order that all people are expected to honor.

Then Amos turns to Judah, Israel’s southern cousin, and the crowd probably cheers. But the last oracle is the longest, and it is against Israel itself. The formula is the same. But the sins are different. The nations were accused of atrocities in war. Israel is accused of oppressing the poor in times of peace: selling the righteous for silver, trampling the needy, profaning God’s name through sexual exploitation, taking garments in pledge and drinking wine bought with fines. The sins are social and economic. They are everyday injustices committed under cover of respectable religion.

God reminds them of his grace: “It was I who brought you up out of the land of Egypt.” He destroyed the Amorites before them. He raised up prophets and Nazirites. They have responded by making the Nazirites drink wine and silencing the prophets. This is the heart of the charge. Privilege increases responsibility. “You only have I known of all the families of the earth” (3:2). Having received more, they are held to a higher standard.

The consequence is a judgment so complete that “the one who is stout of heart among the mighty shall flee away naked.” No strength will help.

The message of Amos is that God cares about how we treat each other. A faith that has no effect on how we treat the poor is not faith. The same God who roars from Zion is the God who sees the needy sold for a pair of sandals.

STEP 5

Connection

James 1:27 says that pure religion is to visit orphans and widows in their affliction. Jesus said, “Everyone to whom much was given, of him much will be required” (Luke 12:48). Amos speaks to the problem Jesus addressed in Matthew 23:23: neglecting justice, mercy, and

faithfulness while tithing mint and dill. 1 Peter 4:17 says that judgment begins at the household of God. Jesus came to proclaim good news to the poor (Luke 4:18).

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your faith has any effect on how you treat the poor and the vulnerable.

Examine your business or workplace dealings. Is there any unfairness you tolerate?

Remember that you have been given much. What does that require?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess the injustices you overlook.

Ask him to let your faith show in how you treat the vulnerable.

Thank him for bringing his people home.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 51

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

AMOS 5:24

DAY 355 · WEEK 51

Amos 3:1-5:27

The covenant lawsuit; seek the LORD and live

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Amos 3:1-5:27. These chapters contain three “Hear this word” sermons against Israel, with famous calls to seek the LORD and to let justice roll down. Look for what God says about worship.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Having announced judgment, Amos now explains why. These chapters are made up of three sermons, each beginning with “Hear this word.” They accuse Israel of oppression and complacency, and of a worship that was lavish but empty. In the middle, there are calls to repentance. The language is vivid and sharp, and includes some of the most quoted lines in the prophets.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “You only have I known of all the families of the earth; therefore I will punish you for all your iniquities” (3:2).
2. “Do two walk together, unless they have agreed to meet?” (3:3).
3. “For the Lord GOD does nothing without revealing his secret to his servants the prophets” (3:7).
4. “The lion has roared; who will not fear? The Lord GOD has spoken; who can but prophesy?” (3:8).
5. “Hear this word, you cows of Bashan, who are on the mountain of Samaria, who oppress the poor” (4:1).
6. “Yet you did not return to me, declares the LORD” (4:6, 8, 9, 10, 11).

7. “Seek me and live” (5:4). “Seek good, and not evil, that you may live” (5:14).
8. “I hate, I despise your feasts, and I take no delight in your solemn assemblies… But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream” (5:21, 24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 3 opens with one of the most important principles in the prophets: privilege means accountability. “You only have I known… therefore I will punish you.” To be known by God means to be held to his standards. Israel assumed that being God’s people guaranteed protection. Amos says it guarantees accountability.

The series of rhetorical questions in 3:3-8 establishes cause and effect. Do two walk together unless they agree? Does a lion roar without prey? Does a trap spring without bait? Does disaster come to a city unless the LORD has done it? The point is that nothing happens without a cause, and the prophets speak because God has spoken. Amos is not a free agent. “The Lord GOD has spoken; who can but prophesy?”

Chapter 4 addresses the wealthy women of Samaria, whom Amos calls “cows of Bashan,” who oppress the poor and say to their husbands, “Bring, that we may drink!” It then describes God’s attempts to get Israel’s attention: famine, drought, blight, plague, and defeat. After each, the same refrain: “Yet you did not return to me.” It is one of the saddest lines in the Bible. God had been calling through hardship, and they did not listen. The chapter ends with the warning, “Prepare to meet your God, O Israel!”

Chapter 5 begins with a funeral song for Israel and then offers a way out: “Seek me and live.” The alternative is to seek Bethel, Gilgal, and Beersheba, the places of religious activity. God says, “Do not seek Bethel.” The religion of the nation had become a substitute for the LORD himself.

The center of the section is 5:21-24. God says that he hates their feasts. He will not listen to their songs. He rejects their offerings. What he wants is justice and righteousness: “Let justice roll down like waters.” This does not mean that worship is unimportant. It means that worship divorced from justice is an offense. The two belong together.

STEP 5

Connection

Martin Luther King Jr. and many others have quoted 5:24 as a call to justice. Jesus echoed the prophets: “Not everyone who says to me, Lord, Lord, will enter the kingdom of heaven” (Matthew 7:21). Hebrews 12:25-29 warns against refusing the one who speaks. Revelation

22:17 echoes the call to seek and live. Jesus is the one who "fulfills all righteousness" (Matthew 3:15) and will establish justice (Isaiah 42:1-4).

STEP 6

Application

Ask if your worship and your daily life belong together, or whether there is a gap.

Look back at "Yet you did not return to me." Is God calling you through something right now?

Pray for justice to roll down like waters in your community, and ask how you can take part.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess any gap between your praise and your life.
- Ask him to let you return when he calls you through hardship.
- Ask him to let justice roll in your community.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 51

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

AMOS 5:24

DAY 356 · WEEK 51

Amos 6:1-9:15

Woes; visions; the booth of David rebuilt

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Amos 6:1-9:15. The book ends with woes against the complacent, five visions of judgment, a confrontation with the priest of Bethel, and a final promise of restoration. Read the closing verses slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The last chapters of Amos strip away the last illusions. The wealthy are comfortable and indifferent. Visions of locusts, fire, a plumb line, and a basket of summer fruit show that the end is near. Then, in the last paragraph, the tone changes completely. God promises to rebuild David's fallen shelter and to restore his people. It is among the great hopeful notes in the prophets.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Woe to those who are at ease in Zion, and to those who feel secure on the mountain of Samaria" (6:1).
2. "Who lie on beds of ivory and stretch themselves out on their couches… but are not grieved over the ruin of Joseph" (6:4-6).
3. Amos sees a plumb line: "Behold, I am setting a plumb line in the midst of my people Israel; I will never again pass by them" (7:7-8).
4. Amaziah the priest tells Amos to go home. Amos says, "I was no prophet, nor a prophet's son, but I was a herdsman and a dresser of sycamore figs. But the LORD took me from following the flock" (7:14-15).
5. A basket of summer fruit: "The end has come upon my people Israel" (8:1-2).

6. “Hear this, you who trample on the needy and bring the poor of the land to an end” (8:4).
7. “Behold, the days are coming… when I will send a famine on the land… of hearing the words of the LORD” (8:11).
8. “In that day I will raise up the booth of David that is fallen and repair its breaches, and raise up its ruins and rebuild it as in the days of old” (9:11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The woes of chapter 6 describe a comfortable elite: lying on ivory couches, eating lambs from the flock, singing idle songs, drinking wine by the bowl, and anointing themselves with the best oils. “But they are not grieved over the ruin of Joseph.” The problem is not wealth itself but indifference. They are at ease while the nation is falling apart. Complacency is a sin when others suffer.

The visions show God’s patience and its limit. In the first two visions, Amos pleads, and God relents. In the third, a plumb line, there is no more relenting. The plumb line measures a wall. The wall is crooked, and it will be torn down. The standard is God’s own righteousness, and Israel does not match it.

Amaziah, the priest, tries to silence Amos: “Never again prophesy at Bethel, for it is the king’s sanctuary.” The priest’s complaint is revealing. The place of worship has become the king’s property. Amos answers by telling his story. He was a farmer. God took him. He has no choice but to speak. A person called by God cannot be silenced by human authority.

Chapter 8 describes a famine unlike any other, not of bread or water but of hearing the words of the LORD. When God’s word is rejected long enough, it is withdrawn. It is one of the most frightening judgments in the Bible. Yet it also shows how precious the word of God is.

But the book does not end in judgment. The last words are promises: God will raise up the fallen booth of David, restore the fortunes of his people, and plant them in their land, “never again to be uprooted.” The same God who judges also restores. The nations are included: “that they may possess the remnant of Edom and all the nations who are called by my name.” The hope reaches beyond Israel.

STEP 5

Connection

In Acts 15:15-18, James quotes Amos 9:11-12 to show that the inclusion of the Gentiles in the church fulfills God’s promise to rebuild David’s tent. Jesus is the son of David who rebuilds the ruins. Jesus said, “Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from

the mouth of God" (Matthew 4:4). John 12:48 and Hebrews 2:3 warn about neglecting God's word. Luke 16:19-31, the rich man and Lazarus, is a New Testament echo of Amos 6.

STEP 6

Application

Ask if you are at ease while others suffer. What would it look like to be grieved over the ruin of Joseph?

Treasure God's word, and use it, knowing that there can be a famine of hearing it.

Thank God for the promise to rebuild David's fallen tent, fulfilled in Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have grown complacent.
- Ask him to grieve you over what grieves him.
- Ask him to measure you by his plumb line and make you straight.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 51

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

AMOS 5:24

DAY 357 · WEEK 51

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Amos 5:24 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

AMOS 5:24

REST

Meditation

This verse is the climax of God's message through Amos. It comes right after God says that he hates their feasts, despises their assemblies, and will not listen to their songs. What he wants in place of all that is this.

"But let justice roll down like waters." The image is of a flood. The Hebrew word for "roll down" suggests a torrent of water in a wadi, pouring through a dry land. It is not a trickle or a drip. The picture is of justice as something abundant, powerful, and unstoppable.

"Justice" is about fairness, the setting right of wrongs. It means that the poor are not trampled, that the weak are protected, that courts are honest, and that the powerful are held accountable.

“And righteousness like an ever-flowing stream.” Righteousness is the character that produces justice: faithfulness to God and to others. The stream is “ever-flowing,” like a perennial spring that does not dry up in summer. Righteousness is not an occasional burst but a constant supply.

In a land where many streams dried up each summer, the image of an ever-flowing stream would have been especially welcome. God wants a justice that does not fail.

How does this verse apply to us? It does not tell us to stop worshiping. It tells us that worship and justice belong together. Our songs and prayers must flow into our workplaces, our families, and our communities.

For the Christian, the source of this stream is Christ. He is the righteous one, who brings justice to the nations (Isaiah 42:1-4). And his Spirit is the living water that flows from within his people (John 7:38). Ask him to make you a channel of justice.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed the divided kingdom into the age of the writing prophets. You read the paradox of Jeroboam II’s prosperity, and the collapse of the northern kingdom that came after. You read the psalms of Asaph and of David that warn against empty religion and boasting in evil. And you spent the end of the week with Amos, the shepherd from Tekoa who announced judgment on the nations and then on Israel, because those who had been given much had trampled the poor. You heard God say that he hates their feasts and wants justice to roll down like waters. And you ended with the promise that God will rebuild David’s fallen shelter. The week taught that privilege brings responsibility, that worship without justice is an offense, and that God keeps his promise of restoration.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

God says through Amos that he hates empty worship. What would make your worship more real this week, in your heart and in how you live?

Amos 9:11-12 promises the rebuilding of David’s fallen tent, and Acts 15 says this is fulfilled in Christ and the church. How does this change how you see the church, and the nations who are part of it?

Who are the “poor and needy” in your life, and what does it mean for justice to roll down toward them?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to let justice roll down like waters.

Thank him for rebuilding David's fallen tent in Christ.

Ask him to make you a channel of his justice.

DAY 358 · WEEK 52

Psalm 58

Do you indeed decree what is right?

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 58. It is one of the hardest psalms in the Psalter, a cry for God to judge unjust rulers. Read it as the voice of the oppressed asking for justice, and notice where it ends.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 58 is a Miktam of David set to the tune "Do Not Destroy." It addresses corrupt rulers and judges, the very people Amos condemned for trampling the poor. This is the first of five psalms in this unit about injustice, and the Psalter's prayer for God to act as judge when human courts fail.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Do you indeed decree what is right, O gods? Do you judge the children of man uprightly?" (v. 1).
2. "No, in your hearts you devise wrongs; your hands deal out violence on earth" (v. 2).
3. "The wicked are estranged from the womb; they go astray from birth, speaking lies" (v. 3).
4. "They have venom like the venom of a serpent, like the deaf adder that stops its ear" (vv. 4-5).
5. "O God, break the teeth in their mouths; tear out the fangs of the young lions, O LORD!" (v. 6).
6. "Let them be like the snail that dissolves into slime" (v. 8).
7. "The righteous will rejoice when he sees the vengeance" (v. 10).

8 “Surely there is a reward for the righteous; surely there is a God who judges on earth” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening question is directed at those who hold power in the courts, possibly human judges or rulers. They are supposed to “decree what is right,” but their hearts devise wrongs. The scandal is not just that they commit injustice, but that they do it while sitting in judgment. When the institutions designed to protect the weak become tools of the strong, the cry for justice goes up.

The language of the psalm is vivid and violent: teeth broken, fangs torn out, a snail melting. These are not private threats but prayers addressed to God. The psalmist does not take up the sword. He asks God to act. It is important to see this difference. The imprecatory psalms place vengeance in God’s hands. They express honest anger at evil and trust that God will deal with it.

How should Christians read such psalms? We cannot treat them as a license for personal hatred. Jesus taught us to love our enemies and pray for those who persecute us. Yet these psalms still teach us something. They teach that God cares about injustice, that evil is not trivial, and that it is right to want it stopped. They give voice to those who suffer under oppression and who have no other recourse. We can pray them on behalf of the oppressed, and ultimately we can read them in light of the cross, where God’s judgment on evil was carried out in Christ, and at the last day, when it will be completed.

The key line is the last: “Surely there is a God who judges on earth.” It is a statement of faith in the face of apparent injustice. Evil does not have the last word. The psalm teaches us to wait for the God who sees.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness” (Matthew 5:6), and told of a widow who pleaded with an unjust judge until God’s justice was shown (Luke 18:1-8). Revelation 6:9-10 shows the souls of martyrs crying, “How long?” Paul says, “Never avenge yourselves, but leave it to the wrath of God” (Romans 12:19). Acts 17:31 says God has fixed a day on which he will judge the world in righteousness by a man whom he has appointed.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for someone who is suffering under an unjust system, and ask God to act.

Examine your own use of whatever power you have. Are you using it for justice?

Remember that vengeance belongs to God, and trust him with what you cannot fix.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to break the power of the oppressor and defend the weak.
- Ask him to keep you from taking vengeance yourself.
- Tell him you believe there is a God who judges on earth.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 52

"And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy."

HOSEA 2:19

DAY 359 · WEEK 52

Psalm 82

God has taken his place in the divine council

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 82. It is a short psalm in which God holds court over the “gods” and condemns them for judging unjustly. Read it slowly, and notice that Jesus quotes it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 82 is a psalm of Asaph. It describes God taking his place in the divine council and passing judgment on those called “gods.” Interpreters differ on who these are: human judges and rulers, or heavenly beings who held authority over the nations. Either way, the psalm’s point is clear: all who hold power answer to the LORD. It pairs with Psalm 58 as a statement of God’s concern for the weak.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “God has taken his place in the divine council; in the midst of the gods he holds judgment” (v. 1).
2. “How long will you judge unjustly and show partiality to the wicked?” (v. 2).
3. “Give justice to the weak and the fatherless; maintain the right of the afflicted and the destitute” (v. 3).
4. “Rescue the weak and the needy; deliver them from the hand of the wicked” (v. 4).
5. “They have neither knowledge nor understanding, they walk about in darkness; all the foundations of the earth are shaken” (v. 5).
6. “I said, You are gods, sons of the Most High, all of you” (v. 6).
7. “Nevertheless, like men you shall die, and fall like any prince” (v. 7).
8. “Arise, O God, judge the earth! For you shall inherit all the nations!” (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens in a courtroom in heaven. God is the judge, and those who stand before him are called "gods." The word elohim in the Hebrew can refer to God, to angels, or to human authorities who act in God's name. Some read the "gods" as the spiritual powers behind the nations, and others as human judges, called gods because they exercise God-given authority. In either case, the meaning of the psalm is the same. Those entrusted with rule are accountable to the one who rules over all.

God's charge is about the poor. He does not accuse them of false doctrine. He accuses them of partiality and injustice. The tests of a ruler are: do the weak receive justice? Are the fatherless and the afflicted protected? God lists four things: give justice, maintain rights, rescue, and deliver. These are the duties of anyone with power.

Verse 5 describes the consequence. When rulers fail, "all the foundations of the earth are shaken." Injustice at the top destabilizes everything. A society that does not protect its weakest members loses its footing.

Verse 6 and 7 are the heart of the psalm. God says that he appointed them: "You are gods, sons of the Most High." They have a high calling. But they will die like any man. The honor of their office does not make them immortal. The psalm humbles all who hold power.

The final verse is a prayer: "Arise, O God, judge the earth!" When human rulers fail, the psalmist turns to God. He is the only perfectly just ruler, and he will inherit all the nations.

When Jesus was accused of blasphemy for calling himself the Son of God, he quoted verse 6 (John 10:34-36). If Scripture could call mere human rulers "gods" because the word of God came to them, how much more could the one whom the Father consecrated and sent into the world claim to be God's Son?

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus quotes this psalm in John 10:34-36. He is the true judge, to whom the Father has given all judgment (John 5:22). Colossians 2:15 says that Christ disarmed the rulers and authorities. 1 Corinthians 15:24-25 says he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. The psalm's last line is fulfilled in Revelation 11:15: "The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ."

STEP 6

Application

If you have authority at work, in your family, or in your church, ask how you treat the weak.

Pray for rulers to remember they will die, and that they answer to God.

Pray “Arise, O God, judge the earth” for a specific situation of injustice.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Pray for those in authority to give justice to the weak.

Ask him to keep you from abusing any power you have.

Praise him as judge of all the earth.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 52

“And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy.”

HOSEA 2:19

DAY 360 · WEEK 52

Psalm 94

O LORD, God of vengeance, the cry for justice

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 94. It is a prayer to the God of vengeance for the oppressed. Notice how it moves from complaint to teaching, and from anxiety to the comfort of God's steadfast love.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 94 has no title. It is a communal and personal lament, and it is also a wisdom psalm, with a section that instructs the arrogant. The enemies are oppressors within the covenant community, who "kill the widow and the sojourner, and murder the fatherless." It is the third of the psalms of justice in this unit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, God of vengeance, O God of vengeance, shine forth!" (v. 1).
2. "Rise up, O judge of the earth; repay to the proud what they deserve!" (v. 2).
3. "How long shall the wicked, O LORD, how long shall the wicked exult?" (v. 3).
4. "They kill the widow and the sojourner, and murder the fatherless; and they say, The LORD does not see" (vv. 6-7).
5. "He who planted the ear, does he not hear? He who formed the eye, does he not see?" (v. 9).
6. "Blessed is the man whom you discipline, O LORD, and whom you teach out of your law" (v. 12).
7. "When I thought, My foot slips, your steadfast love, O LORD, held me up" (v. 18).
8. "When the cares of my heart are many, your consolations cheer my soul" (v. 19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a bold double address: “O God of vengeance.” The word “vengeance” here means just retribution, the action of a judge who puts things right. It is not petty revenge. The psalmist asks God to “shine forth,” to appear as a judge and deal with the proud.

The complaint is fully honest. The wicked exult. They boast. They crush God’s people. And they say, “The LORD does not see.” This is the arrogance of those who think no one is watching. The psalmist answers them with a rhetorical question: “He who planted the ear, does he not hear? He who formed the eye, does he not see?” It is the answer of logic. The Creator of ears and eyes must himself hear and see. God’s knowledge is not less than ours but infinitely greater.

Then the psalm shifts to a more personal note. “Blessed is the man whom you discipline, O LORD, and whom you teach out of your law, to give him rest from days of trouble.” A person who is taught by God finds rest even in times of trouble. This is a different way to see suffering: as a place of instruction. The psalmist knows that the LORD will not forsake his people.

The center of the psalm’s comfort is verses 18 and 19. “When I thought, My foot slips, your steadfast love held me up.” The psalmist’s footing was failing. And God’s covenant love caught him. And when the cares of his heart multiplied, God’s consolations cheered his soul. The word “cares” can mean also “anxious thoughts.” When anxieties pile up, God’s comfort is greater.

The psalm ends in confidence: “The LORD has become my stronghold, and my God the rock of my refuge. He will bring back on them their iniquity.” God will deal with the wicked in his own time. Meanwhile, he is a refuge.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said that nothing is hidden that will not be made known (Luke 12:2-3), and that the Father sees in secret (Matthew 6:4). Hebrews 12:5-11 draws on this teaching about discipline. Philippians 4:6-7 speaks of casting anxieties on God. 1 Peter 5:7 says, “Casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you.” 2 Corinthians 1:3-5 describes God as the Father of mercies and God of all comfort.

STEP 6

Application

When anxious thoughts multiply, pray verse 19 and let God’s consolations cheer you.

Ask whether you ever act as if God does not see. Bring any hidden thing to him.

Thank God that when your foot slips, his steadfast love holds you up.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to shine forth against injustice.
- Thank him that when your foot slips he holds you.
- Ask him to console you when cares are many.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 52

"And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy."

HOSEA 2:19

DAY 361 · WEEK 52

Psalm 109

Be not silent, O God of my praise, the cry against the wicked

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 109. This is the most severe of the imprecatory psalms. Read it carefully, ask whose voice is speaking in the middle section, and watch how the psalm ends.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 109 is a psalm of David, and the psalmist is the target of slander and false accusation. He prays against a particular enemy with one of the longest curses in the Bible. Interpreters differ on whether verses 6 to 19 are the psalmist's curse or a quotation of what his enemies say about him. Whichever reading is taken, the psalm shows what to do with the deepest anger: bring it to God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Be not silent, O God of my praise!" (v. 1).
2. "For wicked and deceitful mouths are opened against me, speaking against me with lying tongues" (v. 2).
3. "In return for my love they accuse me, but I give myself to prayer" (v. 4).
4. "So they reward me evil for good, and hatred for my love" (v. 5).
5. The long curse: "May his days be few; may another take his office" (vv. 6-19).
6. "But you, O GOD my Lord, deal on my behalf for your name's sake; because your steadfast love is good, deliver me!" (v. 21).
7. "For I am poor and needy, and my heart is stricken within me" (v. 22).
8. "For he stands at the right hand of the needy, to save him from those who condemn his soul to death" (v. 31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a plea for God not to be silent. The psalmist has been slandered. The attack is cruel because it is unprovoked: “In return for my love they accuse me.” His response is not to retaliate but to pray: “I give myself to prayer.” The Hebrew is literally, “I am prayer.” His whole life has become an act of prayer in the face of attack.

The long section in verses 6 to 19 is severe. The language is of a legal curse on a specific person: may he be condemned, may his prayer be counted as sin, may his children be fatherless. Many readers find this unsettling, and it is. Some scholars suggest that verses 6 to 19 are a quotation of the accusers’ words against the psalmist, which he then answers beginning in verse 21. In that reading, he is quoting their curses and handing them to God. Others understand the section as his own prayer against an unrepentant persecutor. In either case, the psalm shows what the Bible allows: raw honesty before God about injustice.

Whatever one concludes, the key move is what the psalmist does next. He does not stop with the curse. He turns to God: “But you, O GOD my Lord, deal on my behalf for your name’s sake.” He appeals not to his own righteousness but to God’s name and steadfast love. “Because your steadfast love is good, deliver me!” He admits that he is “poor and needy.” He is desperate.

The psalm ends with confidence and praise: “With my mouth I will give great thanks to the LORD.” He will praise in the midst of the throng. The reason is verse 31: God “stands at the right hand of the needy.” Where an accuser stands at the right hand of the wicked (v. 6), God stands at the right hand of the poor, as an advocate.

The psalm shows us that we may bring even our darkest feelings to God, and that he will turn them toward trust.

STEP 5

Connection

Peter quotes verse 8 in Acts 1:20 in connection with Judas, and the early church read this psalm as a picture of the suffering of Christ. Jesus was repaid with hatred for his love (John 15:25). On the cross he prayed for his enemies (Luke 23:34). He is the one who stands at the right hand of God as our advocate (Acts 7:56; 1 John 2:1). Romans 12:14 says, “Bless those who persecute you; bless and do not curse.”

STEP 6

Application

If you have a bitter feeling against someone, bring it to God in prayer, not into action.

Remember that God stands at the right hand of the needy, as your advocate.

Pray for an enemy by name, for their repentance and their good.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bring God the accusations or hurts you carry, and give yourself to prayer.

Ask him to deal for you for his name's sake.

Pray for the one who wronged you, as Jesus did.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 52

"And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy."

HOSEA 2:19

DAY 362 · WEEK 52

Psalm 140; Psalm 142

Deliver me from evil men; with my voice I cry to the LORD

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 140 and Psalm 142. The first asks God to protect from violent and slanderous men. The second is David's prayer in the cave. Notice how each ends with a statement of confidence.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 140 is a psalm of David asking for deliverance from violent men. Psalm 142 is a Maskil of David, when he was in the cave, which refers to his flight from Saul in 1 Samuel 22 or 24. They conclude this series of psalms on injustice. In the first, evil men plot. In the second, the psalmist cries out from a place where no one cares for him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Deliver me, O LORD, from evil men; preserve me from violent men" (140:1).
2. "They make their tongue sharp as a serpent's, and under their lips is the venom of asps" (140:3).
3. "I say to the LORD, You are my God; give ear to the voice of my pleas for mercy, O LORD!" (140:6).
4. "O LORD, my Lord, the strength of my salvation, you have covered my head in the day of battle" (140:7).
5. "I know that the LORD will maintain the cause of the afflicted, and will execute justice for the needy" (140:12).
6. "With my voice I cry out to the LORD; with my voice I plead for mercy to the LORD" (142:1).

7. “When my spirit faints within me, you know my way!” (142:3).
8. “I cry to you, O LORD; I say, You are my refuge, my portion in the land of the living” (142:5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Psalm 140, the danger is both physical and verbal. The enemies “plan evil things in their heart and stir up wars continually.” Their words are sharp as a snake’s. The psalmist feels hunted: they have hidden a trap for him and spread a net. His response is not to fight but to pray. “I say to the LORD, You are my God.” It is the simplest declaration of faith. In the middle of danger, he claims his relationship with the LORD.

A phrase deserves attention: “You have covered my head in the day of battle.” In war, the head is the most vulnerable. God has been his helmet. It is a vivid expression of divine protection. And at the end, the psalmist declares confidence: “I know that the LORD will maintain the cause of the afflicted.” He knows. His faith rests not on seeing but on God’s character.

Psalm 142 brings us to the cave. David is alone, hunted, and desperate. He prays aloud: “With my voice I cry out.” There is no pretense. He pours out his complaint and tells his trouble before God. The line that stands out is verse 4: “Look to the right and see: there is none who takes notice of me; no refuge remains to me; no one cares for my soul.” It is the cry of utter loneliness. But the next verse is the turn: “I cry to you, O LORD; I say, You are my refuge, my portion in the land of the living.”

When no human refuge remains, the psalmist declares that God is his refuge. “You are my portion,” he says, as the Levites who had no land received the LORD as their inheritance. Everything has been stripped from David, and he discovers that God is enough.

The psalm ends with a hope: “Bring me out of prison, that I may give thanks to your name! The righteous will surround me, for you will deal bountifully with me.” The cave will not be the last word. He will again be among God’s people.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus, in Gethsemane and on the cross, was alone, forsaken by his disciples (Matthew 26:56). Yet he said, “I am not alone, for the Father is with me” (John 16:32). Hebrews 13:5-6 promises, “I will never leave you nor forsake you,” so we can say, “The Lord is my helper.” Ephesians 6:17 says to take the helmet of salvation. 2 Timothy 4:16-17 echoes Paul’s abandonment and the Lord’s strengthening.

STEP 6

Application

If you feel that no one cares for your soul, pray Psalm 142:5 aloud: “You are my refuge, my portion.”

Pray verse 140:7 and ask God to cover your head in the day of battle.

Look for someone who is alone and take notice of them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you are his and he is yours.
- Ask him to deliver you from evil and to be your refuge.
- Tell him what faints within you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 52

“And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy.”

HOSEA 2:19

DAY 363 · WEEK 52

Hosea 1:1-3:5

Hosea and Gomer; the broken marriage as Israel's story

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 30 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hosea 1:1-3:5. Hosea is told to marry a woman who will be unfaithful, and his marriage becomes a picture of God and Israel. This is one of the most moving stories in the Bible. Read the whole of chapter 2, and ask what God is feeling.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Hosea prophesied in the northern kingdom in the decades before its fall, from the time of Jeroboam II to about 722 BC. He was a contemporary of Amos, but the tone of his message is different. Amos spoke of justice, and Hosea speaks of love. His own marriage becomes a living sermon. God tells him to marry a woman who will be unfaithful, so that he can feel something of what God feels over Israel's unfaithfulness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Go, take to yourself a wife of whoredom and have children of whoredom, for the land commits great whoredom by forsaking the LORD" (1:2).
2. The children are named Jezreel, No Mercy (Lo-ruhamah), and Not My People (Lo-ammi) (1:4-9).
3. "Yet the number of the children of Israel shall be like the sand of the sea... In the place where it was said to them, You are not my people, it shall be said to them, Children of the living God" (1:10).
4. "She did not know that it was I who gave her the grain, the wine, and the oil" (2:8).
5. "Therefore, behold, I will allure her, and bring her into the wilderness, and speak tenderly to her" (2:14).

6. “And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy” (2:19).
7. “And I will say to Not My People, You are my people; and he shall say, You are my God” (2:23).
8. “Go again, love a woman who is loved by another man and is an adulteress, even as the LORD loves the children of Israel” (3:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The story of Hosea is shocking on purpose. God tells his prophet to marry Gomer, and the text implies that she will be unfaithful. Their children are given names that preach: Jezreel, a reminder of Jehu’s bloodshed; No Mercy; and Not My People. The names are a message of judgment. A nation that broke covenant will lose the privileges of the covenant.

Chapter 2 is a courtroom drama that turns into a love song. First, God speaks as a wronged husband. Israel has run after her lovers, the Baals, thinking they were the ones who gave her grain, wine, and oil. “She did not know that it was I who gave her the grain.” Idolatry is ingratitude. It credits the gifts to the wrong giver. God says he will strip away what she was relying on, so that she will see.

Then, in verse 14, the tone changes completely. “Therefore, behold, I will allure her.” After the judgment, God does not abandon her. He takes her to the wilderness, the place of their first love, and “speaks tenderly to her.” The word means to speak to the heart. And he promises to make the Valley of Achor, the valley of trouble, “a door of hope.” He promises a new marriage: “I will betroth you to me forever.” The phrase is repeated three times. And it comes with a list of the gifts of the new covenant: righteousness, justice, steadfast love, mercy, and faithfulness. The result: “You shall know the LORD.”

The names are reversed. “I will say to Not My People, You are my people.” Mercy is given to those who had no mercy.

Chapter 3 is the costly part of the story. Hosea is told to buy back his wife from slavery or prostitution, for fifteen shekels of silver and some barley. This is the picture of redemption. God loves the unlovable and pays the price to bring her home. And the chapter ends by looking forward to the day when Israel will seek the LORD and “David their king.”

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Hosea 1:10 and 2:23 in Romans 9:25-26 and Peter quotes them in 1 Peter 2:10 to describe the church: “Once you were not a people, but now you are God’s people; once you had not received mercy, but now you have received mercy.” Hosea’s redemption of Gomer is a picture of Christ’s redeeming his bride (Ephesians 5:25-27; 1 Corinthians 6:20). Jesus said, “I came not to call the righteous, but sinners” (Mark 2:17).

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on being “Not My People” and now “My People.” What does mercy mean to you?

Ask God to speak tenderly to you in your wilderness.

Think about whom you are tempted to give up on. How does Hosea’s love challenge you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for loving you when you were not his people.
- Thank him for buying you back.
- Ask him to allure you and speak tenderly to you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 52

“And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy.”

HOSEA 2:19

DAY 364 · WEEK 52

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Hosea 2:19 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy."

HOSEA 2:19

REST

Meditation

This promise is spoken to an unfaithful wife. It is the Bible's most tender picture of what God intends for his people.

"And I will betroth you to me forever." To betroth is to make a solemn promise of marriage. It is the beginning of a covenant. Israel had broken the covenant again and again, but God does not take back his love. The word "forever" stands out. This is not a temporary arrangement that could be broken again. It is a permanent commitment.

The word "betroth" is repeated three times in verses 19 and 20, as if God cannot say it enough. A man who had been wronged has every reason to refuse. Yet he says it again and again.

“In righteousness and in justice.” These are the foundation of the new marriage. This is not sentimental love that ignores wrong. It is a love that is built on what is right. In the new covenant, justice is satisfied, not set aside. The cross is where righteousness and love meet.

“In steadfast love and in mercy.” These are the heart of the covenant. Steadfast love is covenant loyalty, the faithful love that does not let go. Mercy is compassion toward the needy. God promises to give them to his people, not because of their record but because of who he is.

The verse that follows adds, “And you shall know the LORD.” The goal of the marriage is a relationship of knowledge. The people will know their husband.

For the Christian, this promise is realized in Christ. He is the bridegroom, and the church is his bride. He has paid the price. “I will betroth you to me forever” is a promise for you, if you are in him. Say it as a statement of what God has done.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the psalms of injustice: Psalms 58, 82, 94, 109, 140, and 142, the cries of those who suffer under corrupt power, with the confidence that there is a God who judges on earth. You saw that Jesus quoted Psalm 82 and that God stands at the right hand of the needy. And you began the book of Hosea, the prophet whose marriage to an unfaithful woman became a picture of God’s love for Israel. You read about the children with names like No Mercy and Not My People, and about the God who allures his wayward bride into the wilderness and speaks tenderly to her. You saw Hosea buy back Gomer, and you heard the promise: I will betroth you to me forever. The week taught that God hears the cry of the oppressed, and that his love is stronger than his people’s unfaithfulness.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The psalms of this week take honest, angry prayers to God. What injustice or hurt do you need to bring to him in prayer rather than in action?

Hosea buys back his unfaithful wife, a picture of Christ redeeming his people. What does it mean to you that you were bought at a price?

God says he will “speak tenderly” to Israel in the wilderness. Where do you need to hear his tenderness right now?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for betrothing you to himself forever.

Thank him for buying you back at the cost of his Son.

Ask him to speak tenderly to you this Sabbath.

DAY 365 · WEEK 53

Hosea 4:1-7:16

"I desire steadfast love not sacrifice"

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hosea 4:1-7:16. The prophet now brings God's charges against Israel: no knowledge of God, empty worship, and a heart that is like a morning cloud. These chapters include the unit's anchor verse, Hosea 6:6. Read it in its setting.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second part of Hosea consists of a series of oracles that mix accusation and pleading. God has a lawsuit against Israel. The charge is unfaithfulness to the covenant: idolatry, injustice, and a lack of the knowledge of God. The priests and the political leaders are especially blamed. The section includes a beautiful invitation to return and a sharp reply that shows how shallow Israel's repentance was.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hear the word of the LORD, O children of Israel, for the LORD has a controversy with the inhabitants of the land. There is no faithfulness or steadfast love, and no knowledge of God in the land" (4:1).
2. "My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge; because you have rejected knowledge, I reject you from being a priest to me" (4:6).
3. "A spirit of whoredom has led them astray, and they have left their God to play the whore" (4:12).
4. "Ephraim is joined to idols; leave him alone" (4:17).
5. "Come, let us return to the LORD; for he has torn us, that he may heal us; he has struck us down, and he will bind us up" (6:1).

6. “Let us know; let us press on to know the LORD; his going out is sure as the dawn” (6:3).
7. “What shall I do with you, O Ephraim? What shall I do with you, O Judah? Your love is like a morning cloud, like the dew that goes early away” (6:4).
8. “For I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings” (6:6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The lawsuit begins with a three-part diagnosis: no faithfulness, no steadfast love, and no knowledge of God. The first two are relational. The third is the root. The people had stopped knowing God. They no longer understood who he was or what he wanted. As a result, the society fell apart: swearing, lying, murder, stealing, adultery. “My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge.” The knowledge in view is not just information but a relationship, the knowledge of a husband and wife. It is the loss of intimacy with God.

Priests are especially blamed. They fed on the sin of the people, wanting them to sin so that the offerings would increase. A priesthood that profits from the sins of the people has lost its purpose.

Chapter 6 opens with what sounds like a model of repentance: “Come, let us return to the LORD.” The words are beautiful. They acknowledge that God has torn and will heal, that he will revive them after two days. But God’s response is devastating: “What shall I do with you?” He knows how shallow it is. “Your love is like a morning cloud, like the dew that goes early away.” Their repentance burns off with the morning sun. It is a feeling, not a commitment.

Then comes the unit’s anchor verse. “For I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings.” The people thought that offering sacrifices would fix the relationship. God says that what he wants is a heart that loves and knows him. It does not make sacrifice meaningless, since God himself commanded it. It means that sacrifice without love is empty.

Chapter 7 continues with a series of pictures of Israel’s folly: a cake that is burned on one side and raw on the other, a silly dove flitting between Egypt and Assyria. Israel is half-baked, unstable, and turning to the wrong help. “They do not cry to me from the heart.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus quotes Hosea 6:6 twice: when defending his eating with sinners (Matthew 9:13) and when defending his disciples on the Sabbath (Matthew 12:7). He told the Pharisees, “Go and learn what this means.” John 17:3 says, “This is eternal life, that they know you the only true God.” Paul longs to know Christ (Philippians 3:10). Hebrews 13:15-16 says that the sacrifices pleasing to God are praise and doing good.

STEP 6

Application

Take Hosea 6:6 with you, and let it search you.

Ask whether your repentance has been like a morning cloud. What would a lasting change look like?

Make time to know God, not just to do things for him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you desire to know him, and ask him to keep your love from fading like a morning cloud.
- Confess where religious activity has replaced your heart.
- Ask him to teach you to love steadfastly.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 53

“But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

JONAH 2:9

DAY 366 · WEEK 53

Hosea 8:1-11:12

Israel's persistent adultery; "How can I give you up?"

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hosea 8:1-11:12. Chapters 8 to 10 describe Israel's idolatry and coming judgment. Chapter 11 is one of the most emotionally powerful chapters in the prophets: God's heart breaks over his people. Read chapter 11 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters continue the lawsuit against Israel. The people have made kings without God's approval, set up idols, and made alliances with Assyria. They will reap what they sow. But in chapter 11, the language changes from a courtroom to a family. God is a father who taught his child to walk, and the child went away. The chapter is among the clearest statements in the Old Testament of God's compassionate heart.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For they sow the wind, and they shall reap the whirlwind" (8:7).
2. "For Israel has forgotten his Maker and built palaces" (8:14).
3. "Sow for yourselves righteousness; reap steadfast love; break up your fallow ground, for it is time to seek the LORD, that he may come and rain righteousness upon you" (10:12).
4. "You have plowed iniquity; you have reaped injustice; you have eaten the fruit of lies" (10:13).
5. "When Israel was a child, I loved him, and out of Egypt I called my son" (11:1).
6. "Yet it was I who taught Ephraim to walk; I took them up by their arms, but they did not know that I healed them" (11:3).
7. "I led them with cords of kindness, with the bands of love" (11:4).

8 “How can I give you up, O Ephraim? How can I hand you over, O Israel?... My heart recoils within me; my compassion grows warm and tender” (11:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sayings of chapters 8 to 10 contain some of the most quoted lines in Hosea. “They sow the wind, and they shall reap the whirlwind.” Sin has consequences that exceed what we expect. A small seed of rebellion grows into a storm. “Israel has forgotten his Maker and built palaces.” The root of the problem is forgetting God, and the result is a grand life built without him.

Chapter 10 contains a call that is both an accusation and an invitation: “Break up your fallow ground.” Fallow ground is hard, unplowed soil. The people’s hearts have become hard. God invites them to cultivate them, to sow righteousness and reap steadfast love, to seek the LORD until he rains righteousness on them. Even in judgment, there is an open door.

Chapter 11 is the emotional center of the book. God remembers when Israel was a child. “Out of Egypt I called my son.” He taught him to walk, held him by the arms, healed him, and led him with cords of kindness. The picture of a parent teaching a toddler to take steps is touching. But the more they were called, the more they went away. They sacrificed to Baals and offered incense to idols. Now they will go into exile.

Then God asks, “How can I give you up, O Ephraim?” The sentence is a cry from the heart. Admah and Zeboiim were cities destroyed along with Sodom. God says, “How can I make you like Admah?” His heart recoils. “My compassion grows warm and tender.” God does not simply carry out judgment. He struggles with it. The text shows his holiness and his love in tension, and love wins: “I will not execute my burning anger... for I am God and not a man, the Holy One in your midst.”

This is a deep statement of who God is. His love is not like human love, which gives up when it is wounded. He is God, and he will not give up.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 2:15 quotes Hosea 11:1 and applies it to Jesus, who was called out of Egypt as God’s true Son, the faithful Israel. Jesus wept over Jerusalem as a hen gathering her chicks (Matthew 23:37). Jesus is the one in whom God’s compassion took flesh. Luke 15:20 shows the father running to the prodigal son. 1 John 4:10 says, “In this is love, not that we have loved God but that he loved us.”

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you have “fallow ground,” areas where your heart has hardened. Begin to break it up.

Take comfort from the image of God teaching you to walk. Where has he held you by the arms without your noticing?

Reflect on “How can I give you up?” and let it settle in your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess what you have sown and fear to reap.
- Ask him to break up the fallow ground of your heart.
- Thank him for teaching you to walk and leading you with cords of kindness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 53

“But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

JONAH 2:9

DAY 367 · WEEK 53

Hosea 12:1-14:9

God's love persists; the promise of return

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hosea 12:1-14:9. Hosea ends with a review of Jacob's story, a final warning, and one of the most beautiful calls to repentance in the Bible. Read chapter 14 slowly, and ask what God promises.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The last section of Hosea draws on Israel's history, going back to their ancestor Jacob, and shows how the nation has repeated his deceit. It then moves to a final accusation and the announcement of judgment. But the book does not end in judgment. In chapter 14 God offers words to say, a promise of healing, and a vision of flourishing. It is among the great gospel passages of the Old Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In the womb he took his brother by the heel, and in his manhood he strove with God" (12:3).
2. "So you, by the help of your God, return, hold fast to love and justice, and wait continually for your God" (12:6).
3. "I am the LORD your God from the land of Egypt; you know no God but me, and besides me there is no savior" (13:4).
4. "I shall ransom them from the power of Sheol; I shall redeem them from Death. O Death, where are your plagues? O Sheol, where is your sting?" (13:14).
5. "Return, O Israel, to the LORD your God, for you have stumbled because of your iniquity" (14:1).

6. “Take with you words and return to the LORD; say to him, Take away all iniquity; accept what is good” (14:2).

7. “I will heal their apostasy; I will love them freely, for my anger has turned from them” (14:4).

8. “I will be like the dew to Israel; he shall blossom like the lily; he shall take root like the trees of Lebanon” (14:5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Hosea revisits the story of Jacob, the schemer who grasped his brother’s heel and wrestled with God. Jacob is a mirror for Israel: a deceiver, a striver. But Jacob also “wept and sought his favor” and met God at Bethel. The point is that the same God who found Jacob can find Israel. “So you, by the help of your God, return.” Repentance is possible, with God’s help.

Chapter 13 contains a reminder that God alone is the Savior. “You know no God but me, and besides me there is no savior.” This is a central claim of the Bible. And in the middle of the chapter, there is an astonishing promise: “I shall ransom them from the power of Sheol; I shall redeem them from Death.” Paul quotes this in 1 Corinthians 15:55, as a proclamation of the resurrection. Even in a chapter about judgment, God declares that he will defeat death.

Chapter 14 is the climax. It begins with a call: “Return, O Israel.” Then God gives them words to use. “Take with you words.” Repentance should not be left to chance. God provides the language: take away all iniquity, accept what is good, we will no more say to the work of our hands, “Our God.” Israel is to confess, to turn from false hopes, to trust in God alone. “In you the orphan finds mercy.”

God’s reply is stunning. “I will heal their apostasy; I will love them freely.” The word “freely” means without any cost, without conditions. This is grace. God’s anger has turned away. The language of the garden follows: dew, lily, roots, branches like an olive tree, fragrance like Lebanon, grain, vine. It is a picture of life and fruitfulness. The barren, unfaithful nation will flourish. “From me comes your fruit.”

The book ends with a wisdom question: “Whoever is wise, let him understand these things.” The ways of the LORD are right, and the righteous walk in them, but transgressors stumble. The hearer must choose.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Hosea 13:14 in 1 Corinthians 15:55: “O death, where is your victory? O death, where is your sting?” Christ’s resurrection fulfills it. Romans 3:24 says we are “justified by his grace as a gift,” echoing “I will love them freely.” Jesus said, “I am the vine; you are the branches… apart from me you can do nothing” (John 15:5). Hebrews 13:15 calls us to offer a sacrifice of praise, “the fruit of lips that acknowledge his name,” echoing Hosea 14:2.

STEP 6

Application

Use Hosea 14:2 as a prayer of repentance today. Say the words God provides.

Receive the promise: “I will love them freely.” What would change if you believed it?

Ask where you are trusting in Assyria, horses, or the work of your hands rather than in the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to take away all iniquity and accept what is good in you.
- Tell him you return to him, and heal your apostasy.
- Ask him to be like the dew to you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 53

“But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

JONAH 2:9

DAY 368 · WEEK 53

Psalm 74

Why do you cast us off forever?

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 74. It is a communal lament over the destruction of the sanctuary. Notice how the psalmist reasons with God, recalling his past deeds and appealing to his covenant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 74 is a Maskil of Asaph. It was likely written after the destruction of the temple by the Babylonians, though the destruction of the northern sanctuaries by the Assyrians also fits. It is placed here as the Psalter's response to the fall of the divided kingdoms. The congregation is bewildered, as Hosea predicted, and asks God how long and why.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O God, why do you cast us off forever? Why does your anger smoke against the sheep of your pasture?" (v. 1).
2. "Remember your congregation, which you have purchased of old, which you have redeemed to be the tribe of your heritage" (v. 2).
3. "Your foes have roared in the midst of your meeting place; they set up their own signs for signs" (v. 4).
4. "They said to themselves, We will utterly subdue them; they burned all the meeting places of God in the land" (v. 8).
5. "We do not see our signs; there is no longer any prophet, and there is none among us who knows how long" (v. 9).
6. "Yet God my King is from of old, working salvation in the midst of the earth" (v. 12).

7. “Yours is the day, yours also the night; you have established the heavenly lights and the sun” (v. 16).

8. “Have regard for the covenant… Arise, O God, defend your cause” (vv. 20, 22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with the question, “Why?” It does not hold back. God has cast off his people, and his anger smokes. The picture of “the sheep of your pasture” reminds us that God is a shepherd. How can a shepherd be angry at his own sheep? The psalmist asks God to look at what has happened. He asks him to walk through the ruins.

The description of the destruction is vivid. The enemies hacked the carved work with axes and hatchets. They burned the sanctuary and profaned God’s dwelling place. The worst part is that God’s own place has been dishonored, and his name reviled. The psalmist is grieved less for his own loss than for the offense to God.

Verse 9 is a sorrowful statement: “We do not see our signs; there is no longer any prophet.” The people are in the silence Amos predicted, a famine of hearing the word of the LORD. No prophet knows how long. It is one of the hardest places for faith: when there is no word.

But in verse 12, a turn: “Yet God my King is from of old.” The word “yet” is the pivot. The psalmist recalls what God did: dividing the sea, breaking the heads of the sea monsters, drying up ever-flowing rivers. He remembers the creation: day and night, sun and moon, boundaries of the earth, summer and winter. The God who ordered the cosmos is the same God who is silent now. Memory becomes the foundation for hope.

The psalm ends with a series of petitions. “Have regard for the covenant.” “Arise, O God, defend your cause.” “Remember how the foolish scoff at you all the day.” The psalmist appeals to God’s own honor. He asks God to act for the sake of his own name and covenant. This is the pattern of prayer when everything seems lost: remember who God is, and ask him to act as he has promised.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus predicted the destruction of the temple (Matthew 24:2) and said, “Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up” (John 2:19). He is the true sanctuary that cannot be destroyed. Hebrews 8:1-2 speaks of the true tent. Mark 4:39 shows Jesus rebuking the storm, like God who “divided the sea.” Romans 8:35-39 assures us that nothing can separate us from God’s covenant love.

STEP 6

Application

When things fall apart, follow the psalmist's pattern: state the complaint, then remember what God has done.

Pray for those whose places of worship have been destroyed or who cannot worship freely.

Pray, "Have regard for the covenant," knowing that God has bound himself to you in Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God about what feels like abandonment.
- Remember aloud that he is King from of old.
- Ask him to remember his covenant and his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 53

"But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!"

JONAH 2:9

DAY 369 · WEEK 53

Psalm 77

I cry aloud to God; I remember your deeds

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 77. You read this psalm in Unit 6. This time read it as the prayer of someone who has lived through national catastrophe. Notice how the psalmist moves from his own distress to the memory of the exodus.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 77 is a psalm of Asaph, and it belongs with the other Asaph psalms of this unit. You read it earlier as an example of the discipline of remembering. Now, at the end of the divided kingdom and the fall of Israel, it takes on a new weight. When God's people were cast into exile, this was the question: has his steadfast love ceased? And the answer given is: remember the exodus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I cry aloud to God, aloud to God, and he will hear me" (v. 1).
2. "In the day of my trouble I seek the Lord; in the night my hand is stretched out without wearying; my soul refuses to be comforted" (v. 2).
3. "I remember God, and I am troubled; I meditate, and my spirit faints" (v. 3).
4. "Will the Lord spurn forever, and never again be favorable? Has his steadfast love forever ceased?" (vv. 7-8).
5. "Has God forgotten to be gracious? Has he in anger shut up his compassion?" (v. 9).
6. "Then I said, This is my grief: that the right hand of the Most High has changed" (v. 10).
7. "I will remember the deeds of the LORD; yes, I will remember your wonders of old" (v. 11).

8 “Your way was through the sea, your path through the great waters; yet your footprints were unseen. You led your people like a flock by the hand of Moses and Aaron” (vv. 19-20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a record of a spiritual struggle. The psalmist cries out. He cannot sleep. His soul “refuses to be comforted.” Even remembering God makes him troubled. This is a striking detail: the thought of God, which should comfort, brings distress because God seems absent. He asks a series of questions that every believer in exile has asked: Will the Lord reject forever? Has his steadfast love ceased? Has he forgotten to be gracious?

These are honest questions, and the Bible includes them. Faith does not require us to suppress doubt. It requires us to bring it to God.

The turn comes in verse 10 and 11. The psalmist says, “This is my grief.” Some read the line as: “It is my weakness that the right hand of the Most High has changed.” The meaning is that he has been looking at the problem from the wrong angle. He decides to change his focus. “I will remember the deeds of the LORD; I will remember your wonders of old.” He deliberately turns his mind from his present trouble to God’s past acts.

He then recounts the exodus. God’s way was in the sea, in the great waters, “yet your footprints were unseen.” This is a striking line. God’s footprints were not visible, but he was there. The people crossed the sea, led by an invisible God. In our own times of darkness, we may not see the footprints, but he is leading.

The psalm ends with a quiet image: “You led your people like a flock by the hand of Moses and Aaron.” It is a modest closing line. God leads through ordinary human leaders. The God of the thunder and lightning also leads like a shepherd.

For a people in exile, this was the answer. Remember the exodus. God has rescued before, and he will again.

STEP 5

Connection

The exodus is the pattern of the greater salvation in Christ, who leads us out of slavery to sin (Luke 9:31 speaks of his “exodus” in Jerusalem). Hebrews 13:20 calls him the “great shepherd of the sheep.” Jesus walked on the sea, and his footsteps were seen by the disciples in the storm (Mark 6:48-51). 1 Corinthians 10:1-4 describes the passage through the sea as a baptism into Moses.

STEP 6

Application

When you feel that God has changed, practice remembering. Write a list of his past deeds in your life.

Bring your honest questions to God. Do not edit them.

Look back for “footprints” you did not see at the time.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Cry aloud to God and tell him what your soul refuses to be comforted about.

Remember one of his wonders and rest on it.

Thank him that he leads like a flock, even through unseen footprints.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 53

“But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

JONAH 2:9

DAY 370 · WEEK 53

Jonah 1:1-2:10

Jonah flees; the storm; the great fish

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 27 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jonah 1:1-2:10. A reluctant prophet runs from God's call, a storm threatens the ship, and a great fish swallows Jonah. Read the story as the Bible tells it: with humor, irony, and a surprising ending.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jonah son of Amittai was a prophet in the northern kingdom during Jeroboam II (see 2 Kings 14:25). God sends him to Nineveh, the capital of Assyria, the empire that will later destroy Israel. For an Israelite, this was the last place he would want to go. The book is unusual among the prophets: it is mostly a story about the prophet rather than his sermons. And it shows that God's mercy reaches those whom Israel considered enemies.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Arise, go to Nineveh, that great city, and call out against it, for their evil has come up before me" (1:2).
2. "But Jonah rose to flee to Tarshish from the presence of the LORD" (1:3).
3. "But the LORD hurled a great wind upon the sea" (1:4).
4. "But Jonah had gone down into the inner part of the ship and had lain down and was fast asleep" (1:5).
5. "I am a Hebrew, and I fear the LORD, the God of heaven, who made the sea and the dry land" (1:9).
6. "Pick me up and hurl me into the sea; then the sea will quiet down for you" (1:12).

7. “Then the men feared the LORD exceedingly, and they offered a sacrifice to the LORD and made vows” (1:16).

8. “And the LORD appointed a great fish to swallow up Jonah. And Jonah was in the belly of the fish three days and three nights” (1:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book begins with a command and a flight. Jonah is told to go to Nineveh, and he goes in the opposite direction. The text notes the movement: he goes down to Joppa, down into the ship, down into the hold. Every step is downward. When we run from God, we go down.

The irony is rich. The pagan sailors are devout and the prophet is asleep. They cry out to their gods, while the one man who knows the true God is unconscious. The captain says to him, “Arise, call out to your god!” using the same words God had said to Jonah in 1:2. When Jonah confesses, “I fear the LORD, the God of heaven, who made the sea and the dry land,” the irony is complete. He says he fears the LORD, yet he is running from him. His words are right, but his life is not.

The sailors are more compassionate than Jonah. They try to row back to land rather than throw him overboard. They pray that they will not be guilty of innocent blood. And when they do throw him in and the sea grows calm, they fear the LORD and offer a sacrifice. The pagans are converted, and the prophet is sinking.

Then God appoints a great fish. The fish is not a punishment but an act of rescue. Jonah was drowning, and God saves him. Chapter 2 is Jonah’s prayer from inside the fish, and it is a psalm of thanksgiving. He describes sinking into the deep, with seaweed wrapped around his head. “I called out to the LORD, out of my distress, and he answered me.” He recalls that he was cast “into the heart of the seas.” He confesses: “Those who pay regard to vain idols forsake their hope of steadfast love.” And he concludes: “Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

The prayer is theologically right, but notice that it contains no repentance for running away. Jonah thanks God for deliverance but does not yet say that he will obey. The fish then vomits him onto dry land. Salvation is God’s work from beginning to end.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “An evil and adulterous generation seeks for a sign, but no sign will be given to it except the sign of the prophet Jonah. For as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the great fish, so will the Son of Man be three days and three nights in the heart of

the earth" (Matthew 12:39-40). Jesus slept in a boat during a storm and calmed it (Mark 4:38-39). He is the one who was thrown into the sea of judgment so that others might be saved. "Salvation belongs to the LORD" is fulfilled in Jesus, whose name means "The LORD saves."

STEP 6

Application

Where are you running from something God has asked of you? Name it.

Notice the grace of God in the "appointed fish" in your life, rescues you did not recognize at the time.

Pray Jonah's last line, "Salvation belongs to the LORD," as a statement of trust.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have run from God.
- Thank him for pursuing you and rescuing you.
- Ask him to help you go where he sends.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 53

"But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!"

JONAH 2:9

DAY 371 · WEEK 53

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Jonah 2:9 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!"

JONAH 2:9

REST

Meditation

Jonah says these words from inside the great fish. He has just been swallowed, and he is saved. The last line has become one of the central statements of the Bible's teaching on salvation.

"But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you." Jonah contrasts himself with those who worship idols, mentioned in the previous verse. They give their loyalty to what is worthless. He will give thanks to the LORD. The sacrifice he promises is not an animal but the voice of thanksgiving. This echoes Psalm 50:14, which you read earlier: "Offer to God a sacrifice of thanksgiving."

"What I have vowed I will pay." Jonah made vows in his distress. Many of us do the same: we promise God things in a crisis. Jonah says he will keep his word. It is a commitment to obedience, and one that he will be tested on when he is called again to go to Nineveh.

“Salvation belongs to the LORD!” This is the summary of the story and of the Bible. Salvation is not something we produce or earn. It is not found in idols, in human strength, or in our own efforts. It belongs to the LORD. He is the one who saves, from the storm, from the deep, from judgment, and from death.

The sailors were saved by recognizing it. Jonah was saved by his rescue. And Nineveh will be saved because the LORD is the God of salvation, whether the prophet likes it or not.

For the Christian, this is the heart of the gospel. “For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God” (Ephesians 2:8). Say this verse when you are tempted to think that you saved yourself, or that someone is beyond saving.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the psalms of lament and justice: Psalms 74 and 77 on the fall of the sanctuary and the memory of the exodus, and Psalms 58, 82, 94, 109, 140, and 142 on the God who judges and defends the poor. You walked through the whole book of Hosea, from the unfaithful wife and the names of No Mercy and Not My People, through the lawsuit against Israel, to the cry of a heartbroken father, “How can I give you up?”, and the promise of healing in chapter 14. You also read the first half of Jonah: a prophet running away, a storm, pagan sailors who feared the LORD, and a fish appointed by God. The week taught that God’s love pursues the unfaithful, that he desires mercy and not sacrifice, and that salvation belongs to the LORD.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Hosea shows God buying back an unfaithful wife. Where do you most need to remember that you were redeemed rather than earned your place?

Jesus said that the sign of Jonah points to his death and resurrection. How does Jonah’s rescue from the deep help you understand the gospel?

Jonah ran from a call that seemed too hard. Is there something you are running from that God is asking you to do?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Offer God thanksgiving for pursuing you.

Pray, “Salvation belongs to the LORD,” and mean it.

Thank Jesus, who entered the depths for you.

DAY 372 · WEEK 54

Jonah 3:1-4:11

Nineveh repents; Jonah's anger, God's mercy

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jonah 3:1-4:11. God commands Jonah a second time, Nineveh repents, and Jonah is angry. The book ends with a question and no answer. Read it slowly and ask what the question is asking of you.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jonah has been rescued and returned to dry land. The word of the LORD comes to him "a second time." This is the last scene of a book that began with a runaway prophet. Nineveh was the capital of Assyria, the cruel empire that would soon destroy the northern kingdom. For Jonah to preach to them and see them spared is a scandal, and the book exposes why.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Now the word of the LORD came to Jonah the second time" (3:1).
2. "Yet forty days, and Nineveh shall be overthrown!" (3:4).
3. "And the people of Nineveh believed God. They called for a fast and put on sackcloth" (3:5).
4. "Who knows? God may turn and relent and turn from his fierce anger, so that we may not perish" (3:9).
5. "When God saw what they did, how they turned from their evil way, God relented of the disaster that he had said he would do to them" (3:10).
6. "But it displeased Jonah exceedingly, and he was angry" (4:1).
7. "For I knew that you are a gracious God and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love, and relenting from disaster" (4:2).

8 “And should not I pity Nineveh, that great city, in which there are more than 120,000 persons who do not know their right hand from their left, and also much cattle?” (4:11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

God gives Jonah a second chance. This is a pattern in Scripture: the God who rescues also recommissions. This time Jonah goes, and his sermon is eight words in Hebrew. There is no call to repent in it, only a warning. Yet the whole city believes. From the greatest to the least they fast and wear sackcloth, and even the king takes off his robe and sits in ashes. The most unlikely audience in the Old Testament responds better than Israel ever did to many prophets.

The king’s reasoning is worth noting: “Who knows? God may turn and relent.” He has no guarantee. He repents on the bare chance of mercy. And God does relent. This does not mean God changed his mind in a way that surprised him. It shows that his threats of judgment are real invitations to repent, and that when people turn, he is always ready to forgive.

Chapter 4 is the real point of the book. Jonah is furious. His prayer reveals why he ran in the first place: “I knew that you are a gracious God and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love.” He quotes the great self-description of God from Exodus 34:6, and he resents it. He did not want Nineveh to be shown the mercy that he himself had just received. The prophet who was rescued from the deep is angry that God rescues others.

God does not rebuke him harshly. He asks a question: “Do you do well to be angry?” Then he uses a plant, a worm, and a scorching wind to teach him. Jonah pities the plant that gave him shade, though he did not make it. Should God not pity a city of 120,000 people, and even the animals?

The book ends with that question, unanswered. We do not know what Jonah did. The question is left for the reader. Will you rejoice in God’s mercy to those you think do not deserve it?

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said that the men of Nineveh will rise up at the judgment and condemn the generation that rejected him, “for they repented at the preaching of Jonah, and behold, something greater than Jonah is here” (Matthew 12:41). Jesus told the parable of the prodigal son, which also ends with an angry older brother outside the feast (Luke 15:28-32). 1 Timothy 2:3-4 says God desires all people to be saved. Acts 10:34-35 shows Peter learning that God shows no partiality. 2 Peter 3:9 says God is patient, not wishing that any should perish.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself who your “Nineveh” is, a person or group you would rather not see forgiven.

Pray for God to show mercy to someone you find hard to love.

Thank God for giving you a second chance, as he gave Jonah.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the second chance he gave you.
- Ask him to search your heart for anger where he is merciful.
- Ask him to teach you to care for those you would rather not.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 54

“He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?”

MICAH 6:8

DAY 373 · WEEK 54

Micah 1:1-3:12

Judgment on Samaria and Jerusalem

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Micah 1:1-3:12. Micah was a prophet from a small town in Judah, and he speaks for the poor against the powerful. Read these chapters as a courtroom speech, and notice who is accused.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Micah prophesied in Judah during the reigns of Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, in the same period as Isaiah and Hosea. He came from Moresheth, a village in the countryside, far from the court. His message is about both Samaria and Jerusalem. Where Hosea spoke of love, and Amos of justice, Micah brings both together and ends with a promise of a ruler from Bethlehem.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Hear, you peoples, all of you; pay attention, O earth, and all that is in it, and let the Lord GOD be a witness against you” (1:2).
2. “Woe to those who devise wickedness and work evil on their beds! When the morning dawns, they perform it, because it is in the power of their hand” (2:1).
3. “They covet fields and seize them, and houses, and take them away; they oppress a man and his house, a man and his inheritance” (2:2).
4. “If a man should go about and utter wind and lies, saying, I will preach to you of wine and strong drink, he would be the preacher for this people!” (2:11).
5. “Is it not for you to know justice?” (3:1).
6. “You who hate the good and love the evil, who tear the skin from off my people” (3:2).

7. “Its heads give judgment for a bribe; its priests teach for a price; its prophets practice divination for money” (3:11).

8. “But as for me, I am filled with power, with the Spirit of the LORD, and with justice and might, to declare to Jacob his transgression and to Israel his sin” (3:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Micah begins with a cosmic summons. All the peoples of the earth are called to hear, and the LORD himself comes down from his temple, the mountains melt under his feet. The first judgment falls on Samaria and Judah for idolatry and corruption. The prophet is so grieved that he goes barefoot and naked and wails like a jackal.

The center of chapter 2 is economic sin. People lie awake at night planning how to seize fields and houses. Because they have the power, they do it. This is not a distant, abstract evil. It is landowners taking the inheritance of poorer families, each one of whom held land as a gift of the covenant. To take the land is to attack God’s gift. And Micah notes that the people prefer false prophets: if a man preaches comfort, wine, and strong drink, he is their kind of preacher.

Chapter 3 turns on the leaders. Rulers who should know justice hate the good. Micah uses a shocking image: they eat the flesh of the people and flay their skin. When they cry to the LORD, he will not answer. Prophets who mislead the people for money will find that the vision becomes night. Then Micah gives his own claim: “I am filled with power, with the Spirit of the LORD.” His message is not his own invention. It has the authority of God’s Spirit.

The chapter ends with a verdict: “Therefore because of you Zion shall be plowed as a field, Jerusalem shall become a heap of ruins.” Jeremiah 26:18 later recalls that this prophecy saved Jerusalem in Hezekiah’s day, because the king listened and repented. Hard words can lead to healing when they are heard.

Yet in the middle of chapter 2, there is a flicker of hope: “I will surely assemble all of you, O Jacob… I will set them together like sheep in a fold.” The LORD will be the king who breaks open the way and leads his people out. Judgment is not the last word.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus announced the good news to the poor (Luke 4:18) and warned against those who devour widows’ houses (Mark 12:40). James 5:1-6 warns the rich who defraud workers. Acts 1:8 promises power from the Holy Spirit to witness, as Micah was filled with the Spirit to declare. 1 Peter 5:2-3 charges elders to shepherd the flock willingly, not for shameful gain.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether any of your gain comes at someone else's expense. Look closely at your work and spending.

Pray for leaders in the church to teach faithfully and not for a price.

Pray for the courage to speak truth, as Micah did, in the power of the Spirit.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you from coveting and seizing what is not yours.

Pray for church leaders to be faithful and free from greed.

Ask him to fill you with power, justice, and might by his Spirit.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 54

"He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?"

MICAH 6:8

DAY 374 · WEEK 54

Micah 4:1-5:15

Bethlehem's ruler; future peace among the nations

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Micah 4:1-5:15. After the judgments of chapters 1 to 3, the tone changes to hope. Read the vision of the mountain of the LORD, then slow down at 5:2, the promise of a ruler from Bethlehem.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These two chapters are the hinge of Micah. After the threat of destruction, God shows what he will do beyond it: gather the nations to Zion, bring peace, and raise up a ruler who will shepherd his people. Verse 5:2 is one of the best known prophecies of the coming Messiah, and it was already being quoted by the scribes in Jesus' day.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It shall come to pass in the latter days that the mountain of the house of the LORD shall be established as the highest of the mountains" (4:1).
2. "Many nations shall come, and say: Come, let us go up to the mountain of the LORD" (4:2).
3. "They shall beat their swords into plowshares, and their spears into pruning hooks; nation shall not lift up sword against nation" (4:3).
4. "But they shall sit every man under his vine and under his fig tree, and no one shall make them afraid" (4:4).
5. "And you, O Bethlehem Ephrathah, who are too little to be among the clans of Judah, from you shall come forth for me one who is to be ruler in Israel" (5:2).
6. "Whose coming forth is from of old, from ancient days" (5:2).

7. “And he shall stand and shepherd his flock in the strength of the LORD” (5:4).
8. “And he shall be their peace” (5:5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Micah 4:1-3 is almost identical to Isaiah 2:2-4, a sign of how important this vision was to the prophets. In the last days, the temple mount will be exalted, and the nations will come, not as conquered subjects but as willing learners. “He may teach us his ways and that we may walk in his paths.” The word of the LORD will go out from Jerusalem. And as a result, the nations will stop fighting. Weapons become farming tools. Everyone sits under their own vine and fig tree, a picture of security and peace.

What makes this vision striking is its setting. It follows the destruction of chapter 3. The very hill that will be plowed like a field becomes the highest mountain. God does not give up on his plan. Out of ruins he builds a worldwide kingdom.

The prophet admits that suffering comes first. Israel will go to Babylon, “writhing like a woman in labor,” but there God will rescue and redeem them. Their enemies think they are finished, but “they do not know the thoughts of the LORD.”

Then comes 5:2. Bethlehem was a tiny village, “too little to be among the clans of Judah.” Yet from it will come the ruler of Israel. God consistently chooses the small things. David had been the youngest son from this same town. And the ruler’s origin is “from of old, from ancient days,” language that points beyond a merely human king. He will “shepherd his flock in the strength of the LORD,” and “they shall dwell secure, for now he shall be great to the ends of the earth.” And the key line: “And he shall be their peace.”

He does not just bring peace. He is peace. The final part of the chapter promises the purging of idols and the removal of every false security. The kingdom is not built on horses and chariots but on the LORD.

STEP 5

Connection

When the magi came to Jerusalem asking where the king of the Jews was born, the chief priests and scribes quoted Micah 5:2 (Matthew 2:1-6). Jesus is the shepherd (John 10:11) and “our peace” (Ephesians 2:14). The nations streaming to the mountain of the LORD are fulfilled in the gathering of the church from every tribe (Revelation 7:9). Isaiah 9:6-7 names the coming child “Prince of Peace.”

STEP 6

Application

Reread Micah 5:2 and thank God for Bethlehem, a small place that held the greatest gift.

Notice where God works through things that seem small and overlooked, including in your own life.

Pray for peace in a specific conflict, and for the day when swords become plowshares.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the ruler from little Bethlehem.
- Ask him to shepherd you in his strength.
- Ask him to be your peace.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 54

"He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?"

MICAH 6:8

DAY 375 · WEEK 54

Micah 6:1-7:20

"Do justice, love mercy"; God pardons iniquity

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 36 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Micah 6:1-7:20. God brings a lawsuit against his people, and Micah answers with the most famous summary of the faith in the prophets. Read 6:8 carefully, then enjoy the ending, which is among the loveliest statements of forgiveness in the Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This final section of Micah is built as a courtroom scene, followed by a lament and a hymn of confidence. God calls the mountains and hills to be the jury, and he asks Israel what he has done to deserve her unfaithfulness. The prophet's answer to the question of what God requires has become a guide for Christians and Jews alike. The book ends not with judgment but with a song about a God who pardons.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O my people, what have I done to you? How have I wearied you? Answer me!" (6:3).
2. "I brought you up from the land of Egypt and redeemed you from the house of slavery" (6:4).
3. "With what shall I come before the LORD, and bow myself before God on high? Shall I come before him with burnt offerings?" (6:6).
4. "Shall I give my firstborn for my transgression, the fruit of my body for the sin of my soul?" (6:7).
5. "He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?" (6:8).
6. "Woe is me! For I have become as when the summer fruit has been gathered" (7:1).

7. “But as for me, I will look to the LORD; I will wait for the God of my salvation; my God will hear me” (7:7).

8. “Who is a God like you, pardoning iniquity and passing over transgression for the remnant of his inheritance? He does not retain his anger forever, because he delights in steadfast love” (7:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The lawsuit opens with God’s tender question: “O my people, what have I done to you?” He does not accuse first. He asks. He reminds them of the exodus, of Moses, Aaron, and Miriam, and of the story of Balaam. Everything he has done has been for their good. “Remember… that you may know the righteous acts of the LORD.”

The people respond with a panic of religious inflation. What does God want? Burnt offerings? Calves a year old? Thousands of rams, ten thousand rivers of oil? Even their firstborn? The questions escalate toward absurdity. They think that if enough is given, God will be satisfied. This is the religion of bargaining, and it is the opposite of the gospel.

The answer in 6:8 is simple and searching. “He has told you what is good.” It is not a secret. The LORD requires three things. To do justice: to act rightly toward others, especially the weak. To love kindness: the word is the covenant love hesed, loyal, merciful love that we should delight in, not merely practice. And to walk humbly with your God: a life lived in daily company with him, aware of dependence. This is Hosea 6:6 in another form. It is the same heart of the faith.

Chapter 7 begins with grief. Micah feels as if he is alone in a world with no godly person left. Even families are divided. But then comes a great “but as for me.” “I will look to the LORD; I will wait for the God of my salvation.” When the enemy mocks, he says, “Rejoice not over me, O my enemy; when I fall, I shall rise.” He accepts the LORD’s discipline because he knows that the LORD will plead his cause.

The book ends with a hymn: “Who is a God like you?” It lists what God does with sin: he pardons iniquity, passes over transgression, does not retain his anger, has compassion, tramples our iniquities underfoot, and casts all our sins into the depths of the sea. He keeps the promise he swore to Abraham and Jacob.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said the weightier matters of the law are justice, mercy, and faithfulness (Matthew 23:23). Hebrews 10:5-10 says that the sacrifices could never take away sins, but the offering of Christ's body does. In Christ the sins are cast into the sea (Colossians 2:13-14; Hebrews 8:12). Ephesians 2:8-10 says we are saved by grace, created for good works. Romans 12:1 calls us to present our bodies as a living sacrifice.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Micah 6:8 and take one concrete action today in each of its three parts.

Consider where you are tempted to bargain with God, as the people did.

Thank God that your sins are cast into the depths of the sea. Say it aloud.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what it looks like for you to do justice, love kindness, and walk humbly this week.

Thank him that he pardons iniquity.

Ask him to teach you to do this out of love and not to earn his love.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 54

"He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?"

MICAH 6:8

DAY 376 · WEEK 54

2 Kings 16:1-17:41

Ahaz; the fall of Samaria, the northern kingdom exiled

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 16:1-17:41. These chapters give the fall of the northern kingdom. Notice the contrast between Ahaz of Judah and the kings of Israel, and read the long explanation in chapter 17 of why Israel fell.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The prophets you have read in this unit, Amos, Hosea, Jonah, and Micah, spoke before this event. Now the narrator tells what happened. In 722 BC, Assyria captured Samaria and took Israel into exile, ending the northern kingdom that Jeroboam had founded two centuries earlier. The southern kingdom of Judah, under Ahaz, was saved for a time, but it followed the same path.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “But he walked in the way of the kings of Israel. He even burned his son as an offering” (16:3).
2. “And King Ahaz went to Damascus to meet Tiglath-pileser king of Assyria… and saw the altar that was at Damascus” (16:10).
3. “In the ninth year of Hoshea, the king of Assyria captured Samaria, and he carried the Israelites away to Assyria” (17:6).
4. “And this occurred because the people of Israel had sinned against the LORD their God, who had brought them up out of the land of Egypt” (17:7).
5. “Yet the LORD warned Israel and Judah by every prophet and every seer, saying, Turn from your evil ways” (17:13).

6. “But they would not listen, but were stubborn, as their fathers had been, who did not believe in the LORD their God” (17:14).
7. “They went after false idols and became false” (17:15).
8. “They feared the LORD but also served their own gods” (17:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 16 describes Ahaz of Judah, one of the worst kings. He burned his own son as an offering, sacrificed at the high places, and when threatened by Syria and Israel, sent the temple treasures to the king of Assyria for help rather than trusting the LORD. Isaiah had told him to trust God (Isaiah 7), but he would not. He then copied a pagan altar he saw in Damascus and had it installed in the temple, pushing the bronze altar aside. A king who should have led the people to God remodeled God’s house to fit the world.

Chapter 17 is the theological summary of the whole northern kingdom. The fall of Samaria is told in just a few verses. The rest is an explanation. Israel fell because they had sinned against the LORD who had brought them out of Egypt. The list is long: they feared other gods, followed the customs of the nations, built high places, set up pillars and Asherim, burned incense, served idols, and sacrificed their sons and daughters. “They despised his statutes and his covenant.”

One line stands out. “They went after false idols and became false.” We become like what we worship. Those who worship empty things become empty. And the writer insists that God had warned them: “by every prophet and every seer.” The judgment was not unjust or sudden. It followed centuries of patient calls to return. Hosea, Amos, and others had given fair warning.

The chapter ends with a tragic picture. The Assyrians resettled foreigners in the land, who feared the LORD in a superficial way while still serving their own gods. “They feared the LORD but also served their own gods.” It is a portrait of syncretism, trying to mix the true God with others. The verse repeats: “To this day they do according to their former manner.”

The warning for the reader is plain. Hearing the word is not enough. The covenant requires faithful obedience from the heart. Judah is next, and the same pattern will bring them to Babylon.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “You cannot serve God and money” (Matthew 6:24). Paul writes that the things which happened to Israel “were written down for our instruction” (1 Corinthians 10:11). 1 John 5:21 ends: “Little children, keep yourselves from idols.” Romans 11:20-22 warns the church not to be proud but to continue in God’s kindness. Samaria later became the place of the encounter of Jesus with a Samaritan woman (John 4) and the gospel’s early spread (Acts 8).

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you fear and serve alongside God. Be honest, and name it.

Remember that you become like what you worship. Ask what you are becoming like.

Thank God for the prophets who warned and for the greater prophet who came.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you listen to what he has already said.
- Ask him to keep you from mixing worship with the idols of your age.
- Name one idol and give it to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 54

“He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?”

MICAH 6:8

DAY 377 · WEEK 54

Review and Reflection

Unit 11 review, The Divided Kingdom & Early Prophets

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings."
>
> HOSEA 6:6

REST

Meditation

This is the anchor verse of the unit, and Jesus quoted it twice. It summarizes what the prophets of the divided kingdom said again and again. Israel had built a religion of rituals and sacrifices while its heart was far from God, and its society was full of injustice.

"I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice." God does not reject sacrifice, for he commanded it. But he refuses sacrifice without love. Ritual that is cut off from covenant loyalty is empty. The heart that gives to God what he wants will also care for the poor, be faithful to the covenant, and refuse idols.

"The knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings." To know God is to be in relationship with him: to trust, to love, and to obey. It is the thing Hosea said was missing in the land. When people know God, they act with justice and mercy. Micah says the same in 6:8, and Amos in 5:24.

Say the verse from memory. Then ask what it would mean for your own devotion. Is there any activity of faith that you do, but without love? What would it look like to know God more deeply this week?

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

This unit followed the divided kingdom from its beginning to its end. After Solomon's death, the nation split. Jeroboam set up golden calves at Dan and Bethel, and "the sin of Jeroboam" became the standard by which each northern king was judged. Prophets arose to call the

people back. Elijah confronted Ahab and Jezebel on Mount Carmel, and Elisha carried on his work with miracles of mercy. Amos preached justice, that it should "roll down like waters." Hosea married an unfaithful wife and showed God's heartbroken, faithful love. Jonah was sent to Assyria and learned that God's mercy reaches even enemies. Micah spoke for the poor and promised a ruler from Bethlehem. Finally, in 722 BC, Samaria fell. The psalms of the unit gave voice to lament, to cries for justice, and to hope. Through it all, God's steadfast love does not give up, and the greater prophet is on the way.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What was the sin of Jeroboam, and why did it become the measure for every northern king after him?

Think about 1 Kings 12:25-33 and what it shows about the danger of making worship convenient and political.

How do Elijah and Elisha point forward to John the Baptist and to Jesus?

Consider the confrontation on Mount Carmel, the still small voice, the raising of the dead, and the feeding of many from little.

What did Hosea's marriage to Gomer teach about the heart of God toward his people?

Consider the names of the children, the purchase of Gomer in chapter 3, and the cry of "How can I give you up?"

What does the book of Jonah teach about the scope of God's mercy, and what does it ask of the reader?

Think about Nineveh's repentance, Jonah's anger, and the unanswered question at the end.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the prophets who warned and for the grace that follows.

Tell him how you want to know him more than offer religious activity.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

DAY 378 · WEEK 54

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Micah 6:8 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?"

MICAH 6:8

REST

Meditation

This verse has been called the whole of religion in a sentence. It follows a series of absurd questions: how many sacrifices would be enough? Micah cuts through them. "He has told you." God's will is not hidden. It is not a puzzle for experts. It has been spoken clearly, and it is simple, though not easy.

"To do justice." Justice is not an idea to hold but a thing to do. It means setting right what is wrong, especially for those who have no power to defend themselves. It is the opposite of the land-grabbing and bribe-taking that Micah condemned.

"To love kindness." The word is hesed, covenant loyalty and mercy. We are not only to practice kindness but to love it, to delight in being merciful, as God delights in showing mercy. It is the difference between a duty performed and a joy shared.

“To walk humbly with your God.” The image is of a companion on a journey. We walk with God, not ahead of him or away from him. Humility means we know we are dependent on his grace, that we did not earn our place beside him.

This verse does not replace the gospel. It describes the life of those who have received it. We cannot do any of these three things by our own power. Jesus did them perfectly in our place, and through his Spirit he now enables us to follow him. Say this verse as a prayer for the week ahead.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the book of Jonah and learned that God’s mercy extends even to Nineveh, and that the prophet who was rescued from the deep was angry at the mercy shown to others. You read Micah, the prophet from a small village, who spoke against land-grabbing, corrupt leaders, and false prophets, and who promised a ruler from tiny Bethlehem who would be the peace of his people. You read the lawsuit of chapter 6 and its great summary of what God requires, and the closing hymn to the God who casts our sins into the depths of the sea. And you read the account of the fall of Samaria in 2 Kings, with its sober explanation: they would not listen. The week taught that God asks for justice, kindness, and humble faith, and that he delights to pardon.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jonah was angry that God showed mercy to Nineveh. Is there anyone whose forgiveness you find hard to accept?

Micah promises that a ruler will come from little Bethlehem, and that “he shall be their peace.” How has Christ been your peace?

Micah 6:8 names three things: do justice, love kindness, walk humbly. Which one do you most need to grow in this week, and what is one step you can take?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what doing justice, loving kindness, and walking humbly will look like for you.

Thank Jesus, who is our peace and casts sins into the depths of the sea.

Rest in him today.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 12 · DAYS 379-420

Hezekiah, Isaiah and the Assyrian Crisis

2 Kings 18-20, Isaiah 1-39, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah

God's holiness, judgment, and the great hope of a servant who will bear the sins of many.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory."

ISAIAH 6:3

Psalms 46, 48, 75, 76, 80, 81, and 83 beside Assyria's threat. Psalms 22, 69, and 89 beside Isaiah's servant.

UNIT 12

In this unit

WEEK 55

379	2 Kings 18:1-20:21	*Reading*
380	Isaiah 1:1-3:26	*Reading*
381	Isaiah 4:1-5:30	*Reading*
382	Psalm 80	*Psalm*
383	Psalm 81	*Psalm*
384	Isaiah 6:1-8:22	*Reading*
385	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 56

386	Isaiah 6:1-7; 1 Peter 1:14-16	*Doctrine*
387	Isaiah 9:1-12:6	*Reading*
388	Isaiah 13:1-17:14	*Reading*
389	Isaiah 18:1-23:18	*Reading*
390	Psalm 75	*Psalm*
391	Psalm 76	*Psalm*
392	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 57

393	Psalm 83	*Psalm*
394	Isaiah 24:1-27:13	*Reading*
395	Isaiah 28:1-30:33	*Reading*
396	Isaiah 31:1-35:10	*Reading*
397	Isaiah 36:1-37:38	*Reading*
398	Isaiah 38:1-39:8	*Reading*
399	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 58

400	Psalm 46	*Psalm*

401	Psalm 48	*Psalm*
402	Isaiah 40:1-42:25	*Reading*
403	Isaiah 43:1-45:25	*Reading*
404	Psalm 86	*Psalm*
405	Psalm 89:1-37	*Psalm*
406	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 59

407	Isaiah 46:1-49:26	*Reading*
408	Isaiah 50:1-53:12	*Reading*
409	Isaiah 53:1-12; Romans 3:21-26; Hebrews 9:11-28	*Doctrine*
410	Isaiah 54:1-57:21	*Reading*
411	Psalm 22	*Psalm*
412	Psalm 69:1-21	*Psalm*
413	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 60

414	Isaiah 58:1-60:22	*Reading*
415	Isaiah 61:1-63:14	*Reading*
416	Isaiah 63:15-66:24	*Reading*
417	Nahum 1:1-3:19	*Reading*
418	Habakkuk 1:1-3:19	*Reading*
419	Zephaniah 1:1-3:20	*Reading*
420	Review and Reflection	*Review and Sabbath*

DAY 379 · WEEK 55

2 Kings 18:1-20:21

Hezekiah's faithfulness; the Assyrian threat; deliverance

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 78 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 18:1-20:21. After the fall of Samaria, Judah stands alone against Assyria. Read Hezekiah's story as a test of what faith does when the empire is at the gate, and notice the sad ending in chapter 20.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Hezekiah became king of Judah around 715 BC, a few years after Samaria fell. He is one of the best kings in Judah's history. He removed the high places, destroyed the bronze serpent Moses had made, and trusted the LORD. Assyria, the empire that had swallowed the north, now turned on Judah. This unit follows that crisis from the viewpoint of the king and of the prophet Isaiah, who spoke to him throughout.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He trusted in the LORD, the God of Israel, so that there was none like him among all the kings of Judah after him" (18:5).
2. "He broke in pieces the bronze serpent that Moses had made, for until those days the people of Israel had made offerings to it" (18:4).
3. "In the fourteenth year of King Hezekiah, Sennacherib king of Assyria came up against all the fortified cities of Judah and took them" (18:13).
4. The Rabshakeh asks, "On what do you rest this trust of yours?" (18:19).
5. "Do not let Hezekiah make you trust in the LORD by saying, The LORD will surely deliver us" (18:30).
6. Hezekiah spreads the letter before the LORD and prays (19:14-19).

7. “For I will defend this city to save it, for my own sake and for the sake of my servant David” (19:34).

8. Hezekiah shows the Babylonian envoys all his treasures, and Isaiah says, “Days are coming when all that is in your house… shall be carried to Babylon” (20:12-18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Hezekiah’s reforms show what real faith looks like in leadership. He did not merely keep the temple clean. He destroyed the bronze serpent, a God-given object that had turned into an idol. Even good things from the past become dangerous when people worship them. The writer says there was none like him in his trust in the LORD.

Then the crisis comes. Sennacherib captures the fortified cities and Hezekiah, at first, tries to buy him off with silver stripped from the temple. It fails. The Assyrian spokesman then delivers a speech designed to break the people’s confidence. He asks the central question: “On what do you rest this trust of yours?” He argues that Egypt is a broken reed, that Hezekiah’s reforms have offended God, and that no god of any nation has ever stopped Assyria. He speaks Hebrew loudly so that the people on the wall will hear. This is psychological warfare.

Hezekiah’s response is the model. He tears his clothes, goes to the temple, and sends to Isaiah. When a threatening letter arrives, he does something striking: he spreads it out before the LORD. He brings the threat into God’s presence and prays that all the kingdoms of the earth may know that the LORD alone is God. God answers through Isaiah and strikes down the Assyrian army in the night.

Chapter 20 turns to Hezekiah’s illness and recovery, and then to a quiet failure. When envoys from Babylon come, he shows them everything, perhaps proud of his wealth, perhaps hoping for an alliance. Isaiah tells him the day will come when it is all carried off to Babylon. Hezekiah responds with a short-sighted relief that there will be peace in his days. The great king who trusted God in the crisis is weaker in prosperity. Faith has to be kept through easy times as well.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Whoever believes in me will not be put to shame” (Romans 10:11 quotes Isaiah). Hezekiah’s prayer, spreading a trouble before the LORD, anticipates Philippians 4:6 and 1 Peter 5:7. Paul calls on us to “take every thought captive” (2 Corinthians 10:5) against arguments raised against the knowledge of God. The bronze serpent lifted by Moses became a picture of Christ lifted up (John 3:14), but it was not to be worshiped in itself.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether anything good from your past, a ministry, habit, or tradition, has become something you rely on more than God.

Take a worry or a threatening message and spread it out before the LORD in prayer.

Watch for pride in good times. Ask God for humility when things are going well.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what voices ask you to rest on something else, and say you rest on him.

Spread your fears before him, as Hezekiah spread the letter.

Thank him for the deliverance he has given.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 55

"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel."

ISAIAH 7:14

DAY 380 · WEEK 55

Isaiah 1:1-3:26

God's indictment; Zion's daughters, covenant lawsuit

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 1:1-3:26. Isaiah is the longest and most quoted prophet in the New Testament. Read the opening chapters as a courtroom scene, and listen for God's offer in 1:18.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah son of Amoz prophesied in Jerusalem during the reigns of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, roughly 740 to 690 BC. He was probably a man of standing in the city, with access to kings. The book that bears his name has sixty-six chapters, and it falls into two great halves: judgment and the Assyrian crisis in chapters 1 to 39, and comfort and the coming Servant in chapters 40 to 66. The first chapter works as a summary of the whole.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hear, O heavens, and give ear, O earth; for the LORD has spoken: Children have I reared and brought up, but they have rebelled against me" (1:2).
2. "The ox knows its owner, and the donkey its master's crib, but Israel does not know, my people do not understand" (1:3).
3. "Bring no more vain offerings; incense is an abomination to me" (1:13).
4. "Learn to do good; seek justice, correct oppression; bring justice to the fatherless, plead the widow's cause" (1:17).
5. "Come now, let us reason together, says the LORD: though your sins are like scarlet, they shall be as white as snow" (1:18).
6. "How the faithful city has become a whore" (1:21).

7 “He shall judge between the nations, and shall decide disputes for many peoples; and they shall beat their swords into plowshares” (2:4).

8 “Stop regarding man in whose nostrils is breath, for of what account is he?” (2:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The prophet opens with God calling heaven and earth as witnesses, as in Deuteronomy. The charge is rebellion by children who have been loved and raised. The comparison is humbling: an ox and a donkey know where their food comes from, but Israel does not. The nation is sick from head to foot, with wounds that no one has treated. They are like Sodom, spared only because a few survived.

The religion of the people is another problem. They keep the feasts, offer the sacrifices, spread out their hands in prayer. And God says he cannot stand it. This does not mean God rejects worship. It means worship from people who plot evil and ignore the oppressed is an offense. Hosea 6:6 and Micah 6:8, which you just read, say the same. The remedy is practical: learn to do good, seek justice, correct oppression, defend the fatherless, plead for the widow.

Then comes one of the great invitations in the Bible. “Come now, let us reason together.” God does not simply condemn. He argues, he offers, and he promises. “Though your sins are like scarlet, they shall be as white as snow.” The cleansing that no sacrifice by itself could provide is offered freely, on the condition that they are willing and obedient. The choice is plain: eat the good of the land, or be devoured by the sword.

Chapter 2 sets a vision of the last days beside the failure of the present. The nations will stream to the mountain of the LORD, as in Micah 4. Then the prophet turns to the pride of Judah: idols, wealth, horses, and haughty looks. God will humble all that is lofty. The day of the LORD is against everything proud. Chapter 3 describes the collapse of social order, with children as leaders and women of Zion strutting in finery that will be replaced by sackcloth.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus quoted Isaiah’s description of hollow worship: “This people honors me with their lips, but their heart is far from me” (Mark 7:6, from Isaiah 29:13). Revelation 7:14 speaks of those whose robes have been washed in the blood of the Lamb and made white. 1 John 1:7-9 promises that the blood of Jesus cleanses us from all sin. James 1:27 defines pure religion as visiting orphans and widows in their affliction.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Isaiah 1:18 and take it as a personal invitation. Name a sin that you carry, and bring it to God.

Choose one act of justice or mercy this week: help a widow, a child, or someone who is being treated unfairly.

Examine your worship. Is there any area where your religious activity is not matched by how you live?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have rebelled as one of God's children.
- Ask him to reason with you and wash your sins white.
- Thank him for his invitation to come.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 55

"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel."

ISAIAH 7:14

DAY 381 · WEEK 55

Isaiah 4:1-5:30

The Branch of the LORD; the vineyard song

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 46 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 4:1-5:30. A beautiful promise of the Branch of the LORD is followed by the famous song of the vineyard. Read the song as a story, and notice how the listeners are caught by it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 4 closes the first section of Isaiah with a picture of a cleansed Jerusalem after judgment. Chapter 5 opens with a love song that suddenly turns into a lawsuit. Isaiah probably sang or recited it publicly at a feast. The vineyard, a common image for Israel, appears again and again in Scripture, in the Psalms (like Psalm 80, in two days), and in Jesus' parables.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In that day the branch of the LORD shall be beautiful and glorious" (4:2).
2. "And he who is left in Zion and remains in Jerusalem will be called holy" (4:3).
3. "Then the LORD will create over the whole site of Mount Zion and over her assemblies a cloud by day, and smoke and the shining of a flaming fire by night" (4:5).
4. "Let me sing for my beloved my love song concerning his vineyard" (5:1).
5. "He dug it and cleared it of stones, and planted it with choice vines" (5:2).
6. "What more was there to do for my vineyard, that I have not done in it? When I looked for it to yield grapes, why did it yield wild grapes?" (5:4).
7. "He looked for justice, but behold, bloodshed; for righteousness, but behold, an outcry!" (5:7).

8 “Woe to those who call evil good and good evil, who put darkness for light and light for darkness” (5:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 4 begins with a bleak scene: seven women clinging to one man because the men have died in war. It shows the depth of the coming loss. Then comes the promise. “The branch of the LORD” will be beautiful and glorious. The word “branch” (Hebrew tsemach) is a title that will later become a name for the Messiah (Jeremiah 23:5; Zechariah 3:8). The survivors of Zion will be called holy. God will wash away the filth and cleanse the bloodstains. And he will cover the city with a canopy of cloud and fire, just as he did in the wilderness. After judgment, a new exodus.

Chapter 5 is a masterpiece of rhetoric. Isaiah sings of a friend who owned a vineyard on a fertile hill. He dug, cleared, planted choice vines, built a watchtower and a winepress. Everything necessary was done. And the vineyard produced wild grapes, sour and useless. The listeners must have enjoyed the song and probably sided with the owner. Then Isaiah turns the question on them: “What more was there to do?” The listeners are the vineyard. God looked for justice, and found bloodshed. He looked for righteousness and heard the cry of the oppressed.

The consequences are given: God will remove the hedge, break down the wall, and let it be trampled. The judgment is the withdrawal of protection. The following six woes detail the sins: greedy land accumulation, drunken feasting, mocking God’s plan, calling evil good, pride in one’s own wisdom, and bribery. Verse 20 is among the most relevant in the whole book. When a society reverses its moral categories, it is ripe for judgment.

The passage ends with the sound of a distant army. God whistles for Assyria from the ends of the earth. It is a dark picture. But the reader knows from chapter 4 that this is not the last word. The Branch will come.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told his own vineyard parable of the wicked tenants who killed the owner’s son (Mark 12:1-12), clearly echoing Isaiah 5. In John 15:1-8 he says, “I am the true vine,” the faithful Israel who bears fruit. Jeremiah 23:5 and Zechariah 6:12 call the Messiah the Branch. Galatians 5:22-23 describes the fruit of the Spirit, the good grapes that God wants.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what kind of fruit your life is bearing. Is it justice, mercy, and righteousness, or sour grapes?

Notice where our culture calls evil good and good evil. Pray for clarity and courage.

Thank God for the Branch, Jesus, who is the true vine, and ask to abide in him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the wild grapes you have produced.
- Ask Jesus, the true vine, to help you abide and bear fruit.
- Thank God for all he has done for his vineyard.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 55

"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel."

ISAIAH 7:14

DAY 382 · WEEK 55

Psalm 80

Restore us, O God, the vine brought out of Egypt

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 19 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 80. It is a prayer of the northern tribes for restoration, and its image of the vine echoes Isaiah 5. Notice the refrain that returns three times, each time with a fuller name for God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 80 is a psalm of Asaph set to the tune "Lilies, a Testimony." It names the northern tribes Ephraim, Benjamin, and Manasseh, and so was probably written around the fall of the northern kingdom. It is placed here to answer Isaiah's vineyard song. Isaiah says the vineyard produced wild grapes. The psalmist asks the vinedresser to come back and tend it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give ear, O Shepherd of Israel, you who lead Joseph like a flock" (v. 1).
2. "Restore us, O God; let your face shine, that we may be saved!" (v. 3).
3. "O LORD God of hosts, how long will you be angry with your people's prayers?" (v. 4).
4. "You have fed them with the bread of tears and given them tears to drink in full measure" (v. 5).
5. "You brought a vine out of Egypt; you drove out the nations and planted it" (v. 8).
6. "Why then have you broken down its walls, so that all who pass along the way pluck its fruit?" (v. 12).
7. "Turn again, O God of hosts! Look down from heaven, and see; have regard for this vine" (v. 14).

8 “But let your hand be on the man of your right hand, the son of man whom you have made strong for yourself!” (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with the image of a shepherd and moves to the image of a vine. In both, God is the caretaker of his people. The psalmist reminds him of what he did: he brought a vine out of Egypt, cleared the ground, and let it take root until it filled the land. The vine reached from the mountains to the sea. Then the walls fell, and the vine was burned and cut down. This is Isaiah 5 from the other side. Isaiah says the vine did not bear fruit. The psalmist pleads that God would not abandon it.

The refrain is the heart of the prayer. It appears three times, with the name of God growing. “Restore us, O God” (v. 3). “Restore us, O God of hosts” (v. 7). “Restore us, O LORD God of hosts” (v. 19). Each time the same request: “Let your face shine, that we may be saved.” As the prayer deepens, the psalmist uses a fuller and more covenantal name. It is the language of someone who is coming closer to God as they pray.

Notice that the psalmist does not ask for the nation to reform itself. He asks God to restore. The people cannot fix their own spiritual condition. “Let your face shine” is the old priestly blessing of Numbers 6. Salvation is the shining of God’s face.

Verse 17 introduces a mysterious figure: “the man of your right hand, the son of man whom you have made strong.” Perhaps this is the king, or Israel as God’s son. But the language points beyond them. The vine needs a representative who will do what the vine failed to do. The psalm ends with a vow: “Then we shall not turn back from you; give us life, and we will call upon your name.” Renewal produces faithfulness.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I am the true vine” (John 15:1), the faithful Israel who bears fruit and in whom we are branches. “The son of man at God’s right hand” is a title Jesus used of himself (Mark 14:62; Daniel 7:13). Hebrews 1:3 says he sits at the right hand of the Majesty. 2 Corinthians 4:6 says God has shone in our hearts “to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ.”

STEP 6

Application

Pray the refrain “Restore us, O God; let your face shine, that we may be saved” for yourself and for your church.

Think about an area of your life that has been “broken down.” Ask God to restore it.

Thank God that the true vine, Jesus, bears all the fruit that Israel did not.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask the Shepherd of Israel to restore you where you are ruined.

Ask him to let his face shine on you.

Thank him for the man at his right hand.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 55

“Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel.”

ISAIAH 7:14

DAY 383 · WEEK 55

Psalm 81

I am the LORD your God, if only my people would listen

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 16 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 81. It is a festival psalm in which God himself speaks and pleads with his people. Notice how it moves from joyful praise to a wistful "if only."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 81 is a psalm of Asaph, to be sung at a festival, probably the Feast of Tabernacles or Passover, as it refers to the new moon and the full moon. The people are called to celebrate. Then, in verse 5, the voice shifts, and God himself speaks. The psalm pairs with Psalm 80: there the people asked God to restore them, and here God asks them why they will not listen.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Sing aloud to God our strength; shout for joy to the God of Jacob!" (v. 1).
2. "I relieved your shoulder of the burden; your hands were freed from the basket" (v. 6).
3. "In distress you called, and I delivered you" (v. 7).
4. "Hear, O my people, while I admonish you! O Israel, if you would but listen to me!" (v. 8).
5. "There shall be no strange god among you; you shall not bow down to a foreign god" (v. 9).
6. "I am the LORD your God, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt. Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it" (v. 10).
7. "But my people did not listen to my voice; Israel would not submit to me" (v. 11).
8. "Oh, that my people would listen to me, that Israel would walk in my ways! … I would feed you with the finest of the wheat, and with honey from the rock I would satisfy you" (vv. 13, 16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first part of the psalm is exuberant. Musical instruments are named: tambourine, lyre, harp, trumpet. The people are told to celebrate because it is a statute for Israel. Worship is an obligation, and it is also a delight.

Then God speaks, and the voice is full of pathos. He reminds them of the exodus: he relieved their shoulders of the burden, freed their hands from the baskets of brick-making, and answered them in the thunder. He tested them at the waters of Meribah. The history is in the background of everything that follows.

God's central appeal is verse 8: "Hear, O my people." It echoes the Shema of Deuteronomy 6. The first commandment follows: no strange god among you. And then a promise that is also an invitation: "Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it." Like a baby bird with its beak open, the people are invited to depend on their provider. God is not reluctant. He has more to give than they dare ask.

The sad part comes in verse 11. "But my people did not listen to my voice." So God "gave them over to their stubborn hearts, to follow their own counsels." Sometimes the worst judgment is to be left to what we want.

The psalm ends with God's wistful "if only." If they would listen, if they would walk in his ways, he would subdue their enemies and feed them with the finest wheat and honey from the rock. This is God's heart. He does not delight in judgment. He longs for his people to listen and to receive his blessings.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest" (Matthew 11:28), the same relief of burdens. John 6:35 says he is the bread of life, the finest wheat. 1 Corinthians 10:4 says that the rock in the wilderness was Christ, from whom flowed the water, and in Psalm 81 the honey. Luke 13:34 echoes the divine longing: "How often would I have gathered your children… and you would not!" Revelation 3:20 shows Christ knocking at the door.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where God is saying "if only you would listen" to you. What is he asking that you have not done?

Open your mouth wide. Bring a large request to God this week, a need for yourself or for others.

Thank God for the burdens he has lifted from your shoulders.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Shout to God for his strength, and tell him why.

Confess where you have not listened to his voice.

Ask him to open your ears.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 55

"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel."

ISAIAH 7:14

DAY 384 · WEEK 55

Isaiah 6:1-8:22

Isaiah's call; Immanuel, God with us

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 6:1-8:22. Chapter 6 is the call vision, one of the most important scenes in the Bible. Read it slowly, then continue into chapter 7, where Isaiah gives King Ahaz the sign of Immanuel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah has a vision of God in the year King Uzziah died, about 740 BC. Uzziah had reigned for fifty-two years, a time of stability, and his death left a sense of insecurity. In chapters 7 and 8, the setting shifts to the crisis of 734 BC, when Syria and Israel allied against Judah and threatened King Ahaz. Isaiah goes out to meet Ahaz and offers him a sign.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In the year that King Uzziah died I saw the Lord sitting upon a throne, high and lifted up; and the train of his robe filled the temple" (6:1).
2. "Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!" (6:3).
3. "Woe is me! For I am lost; for I am a man of unclean lips" (6:5).
4. "Behold, this has touched your lips; your guilt is taken away, and your sin atoned for" (6:7).
5. "Here I am! Send me" (6:8).
6. "If you are not firm in faith, you will not be firm at all" (7:9).
7. "Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel" (7:14).

8 “To the teaching and to the testimony! If they will not speak according to this word, it is because they have no light of dawn” (8:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Isaiah’s vision is the pattern of all true encounters with God. First, God is seen in majesty: seated on a throne, the hem of his robe filling the temple. Seraphim cover their faces and their feet and cry, “Holy, holy, holy.” The threefold repetition is the strongest superlative in Hebrew. Holiness is the one attribute of God that is repeated this way in Scripture. It means that God is utterly set apart, pure, and other. The doorposts shake and the house fills with smoke.

Second, the response is a recognition of sin. “Woe is me! For I am lost.” Isaiah, a respected man, a prophet who had already pronounced woes on others, now sees himself. The nearer one comes to God’s holiness, the clearer one’s own uncleanness becomes.

Third, there is cleansing. A seraph takes a burning coal from the altar and touches his mouth: “Your guilt is taken away, and your sin atoned for.” Isaiah does not clean himself. God provides the atonement, through the altar, a picture of sacrifice.

Fourth, the commission. Only now does God ask, “Whom shall I send?” And Isaiah, forgiven, says, “Here I am! Send me.” Service follows grace. The message he is given is a hard one: the people will hear and not understand, until the land is laid waste. Yet “the holy seed” is the stump that remains.

In chapter 7 the lesson is applied to a king. Ahaz is afraid. Isaiah tells him to be calm and trust. When Ahaz refuses to ask for a sign, with a pious excuse, God gives one anyway: a virgin will conceive and bear a son, Immanuel, “God with us.” In the immediate setting, a child would be born as a sign that the enemy kings would fall before he grew up. Yet the language reaches beyond. The promise is that God himself will be with his people.

STEP 5

Connection

John 12:41 says that Isaiah saw Jesus’ glory and spoke of him. Matthew 1:22-23 quotes Isaiah 7:14 as fulfilled in the virgin birth of Jesus. Revelation 4:8 echoes the seraphim, “Holy, holy, holy, is the Lord God Almighty.” Romans 10:15 asks, “How are they to preach unless they are sent?” 1 Peter 2:8 quotes Isaiah 8:14 about the stone of stumbling.

STEP 6

Application

Spend a few minutes in silence before God's holiness. Let it correct how small your view of him has been.

Confess one sin by name, and receive the cleansing God has provided in Christ.

Pray Isaiah's words, "Here I am! Send me," and ask where God may be sending you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as holy, holy, holy, in your own words.
- Confess your unclean lips, and thank him for taking away your guilt.
- Tell him, "Here I am," and listen.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 55

"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel."

ISAIAH 7:14

DAY 385 · WEEK 55

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Isaiah 7:14 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel."

ISAIAH 7:14

REST

Meditation

Ahaz, king of Judah, was afraid. Two armies were marching against him, and Isaiah met him with an offer: ask for any sign you like, as deep as Sheol or as high as heaven. Ahaz refused with a pious-sounding excuse. He had already decided to trust Assyria instead of God. So the Lord gave a sign anyway.

"The Lord himself will give you a sign." It is a gift that is given whether or not it is asked for. Grace often works like that. God gives more than we ask and sometimes more than we deserve.

"Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son." In Isaiah's time, a young woman would bear a child, and before he was old enough to know right from wrong, the threat from the northern kings would be gone. Matthew, writing under the Spirit's guidance, sees a deeper meaning. The sign finds its full meaning in Mary and the birth of Jesus, born of a virgin.

“And shall call his name Immanuel.” The name means “God with us.” It is the whole message of the gospel in two words. God has not stayed at a distance. He has come near, in flesh, in the middle of our fear and trouble. Ahaz needed to know that God was with him. We need to know it too.

Say this verse when you are afraid. The promise is not that every threat will vanish, but that God is with you. In Christ, the one who is called Immanuel has promised, “I am with you always, to the end of the age.”

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the unit that surrounds the Assyrian crisis. You read of Hezekiah’s trust in the LORD when Sennacherib’s army stood outside Jerusalem, and of his later pride when he showed the Babylonian envoys his treasures. You entered the book of Isaiah, with the courtroom scene of chapter 1 and its great invitation, “Though your sins are like scarlet, they shall be as white as snow.” You read the song of the vineyard, in which God looked for justice and found bloodshed, and you prayed Psalms 80 and 81 for the vine to be restored and for the people to listen. And you stood in the temple with Isaiah, saw the Holy One high and lifted up, heard the cry of “Holy, holy, holy,” and received the sign of Immanuel. The week taught that God is holy, that he provides his own cleansing, and that he is with his people.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Isaiah saw God’s holiness and was undone, then cleansed, then sent. Where are you in that pattern right now?

Jesus is the true vine who bears the fruit Israel never did. What would it look like to abide in him this week?

Immanuel means “God with us.” Where do you most need to remember that he is with you right now?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for Immanuel, God with us.

Ask him to cleanse you, send you, and be with you.

Rest in his presence.

DAY 386 · WEEK 56

Isaiah 6:1-7; 1 Peter 1:14-16

The holiness of God

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Doctrine · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 6:1-7 again, then turn to 1 Peter 1:14-16. Today is a doctrinal pause, so you are reading two passages together: Isaiah's vision of the Holy One and Peter's command that God's people be holy. Ask as you read: what is holiness, and what does it have to do with me?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah saw the Lord on a throne in the temple, and the seraphim cried, "Holy, holy, holy." Seven centuries later, the apostle Peter wrote to scattered believers who were living as strangers in a pagan world, and he took a command from Leviticus: "You shall be holy, for I am holy." Between them stands the central idea of the whole Bible. This is a day to stop and think carefully about what it means to say God is holy.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!" (Isaiah 6:3).
2. The foundations of the thresholds shook at the voice, and the house was filled with smoke (Isaiah 6:4).
3. "Woe is me! For I am lost; for I am a man of unclean lips, and I dwell in the midst of a people of unclean lips" (Isaiah 6:5).
4. "Your guilt is taken away, and your sin atoned for" (Isaiah 6:7).
5. "As obedient children, do not be conformed to the passions of your former ignorance" (1 Peter 1:14).
6. "But as he who called you is holy, you also be holy in all your conduct" (1 Peter 1:15).

7. “Since it is written, You shall be holy, for I am holy” (1 Peter 1:16).

8. The holiness commanded is rooted in the holiness of the one who calls.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

To say that God is holy is to say first that he is different. The Hebrew word means “set apart” or “cut off.” God is not part of creation. He is not a bigger version of us. He is the Creator, infinitely above everything he has made, in power, in knowledge, in being. When the seraphim cover their faces and feet, they show that even the highest created beings cannot look at him without reverence.

Holiness also means that God is morally pure. In him there is no darkness at all (1 John 1:5). He cannot tolerate evil, and he cannot be tempted by it. This is why Isaiah’s response to the vision was not delight but terror. In the presence of perfect purity, his own uncleanness was exposed. Holiness is not a cold attribute alone. It is bound up with God’s love, justice, and mercy. His love is a holy love, and his justice is a holy justice. This is why forgiveness is costly: a holy God cannot simply look away from sin. He deals with it, and he does so by providing atonement. The coal on the altar points to a sacrifice.

Third, holiness is shared. God does not remain in splendid isolation. He calls his people to be holy, as Peter says, in all their conduct. This is what it means to be saved: to be set apart for God, and to be changed to be like him. We are not holy by our own effort. In Christ, believers are already declared holy (1 Corinthians 1:2), and yet we are called to become holy in practice. Holiness is a gift we receive and a goal we pursue by the Spirit.

The right response to a holy God is reverence, repentance, and worship. And the good news is that the holy God has made a way to come near.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Put the two passages side by side and they teach a unified lesson. Isaiah’s vision shows us the God who is holy. Peter’s command shows us what holiness means for those who belong to him. Neither is possible without the other.

Isaiah’s experience follows an order: vision, confession, cleansing, and service. He did not choose to confess. The sight of God’s holiness did that for him. And the cleansing was not earned. The seraph brought the coal from the altar, and the declaration was made: “Your guilt is taken away.” Holiness begins with God’s initiative.

Peter writes to Christians who were tempted to go back to their old way of life. He tells them not to be conformed to the passions of their former ignorance. They once lived without knowing God. Now they have been called by a holy God, and they are to be holy. The command is based on the character of the one who calls. He does not say, be holy because it is difficult and noble. He says, be holy because I am.

The surrounding verses explain the foundation. Holiness comes from knowing that we have been ransomed "with the precious blood of Christ." The holiness that God requires is the holiness that he has paid for. We are not trying to become acceptable. We have been made acceptable, and we now live out what is true of us.

This changes how we think about the Christian life. It is not mainly a list of rules but a way of life that reflects the character of the God we have met. We look at him, and we begin to be changed into the same image.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 12:14 says, "Strive for peace with everyone, and for the holiness without which no one will see the Lord." Hebrews 10:10 says we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ. 2 Corinthians 3:18 says we are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another. 1 Thessalonians 4:7 says God has called us to holiness. Revelation 4:8 shows the living creatures still crying "Holy, holy, holy" before the throne.

STEP 6

Application

Take five minutes to sit before God without asking for anything. Let the word "holy" fill your mind.

Choose one area of life where your conduct does not reflect the God who called you. Ask for the Spirit's help to change.

Thank God that holiness is first something he gives, in Christ, and not something you must earn.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for his holiness, and tell him how it moves you.

Thank him for taking away your guilt through Christ.

Ask him to make you holy as he is holy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 56

"For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace."

ISAIAH 9:6

DAY 387 · WEEK 56

Isaiah 9:1-12:6

The child born to us; the shoot of Jesse; peaceable kingdom

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 83 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 9:1-12:6. These chapters contain the great Messianic promises of Isaiah: the child born to us, the shoot from the stump of Jesse, and the peaceable kingdom. Read them as light dawning in a dark place.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 8 ended in darkness and distress, with a people who consult mediums and find only gloom. Chapter 9 begins with a "but." The land of Zebulun and Naphtali, the first to be devastated by Assyria, will be the first to see light. In these chapters, Isaiah gives his most famous portrait of the coming king, and promises that after the Assyrian axe comes a shoot from the stump of David's family.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The people who walked in darkness have seen a great light; those who dwelt in a land of deep darkness, on them has light shone" (9:2).
2. "For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder" (9:6).
3. "And his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace" (9:6).
4. "Of the increase of his government and of peace there will be no end" (9:7).
5. "For all this his anger has not turned away, and his hand is stretched out still" (9:12).
6. "There shall come forth a shoot from the stump of Jesse, and a branch from his roots shall bear fruit" (11:1).

7. “The Spirit of the LORD shall rest upon him, the Spirit of wisdom and understanding” (11:2).

8. “The wolf shall dwell with the lamb… for the earth will be full of the knowledge of the LORD as the waters cover the sea” (11:6, 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The light in chapter 9 is a reversal. Isaiah says the very place that first suffered under Assyria will be honored. Galilee, a region in the far north that was despised, becomes the setting for the good news. The prophecy then explains why: a child is born. The one who comes is a human child, born into the line of David, and yet his names point beyond the human. “Mighty God” and “Everlasting Father” are titles that no merely human king could carry. “Wonderful Counselor” means that he needs no advice, and “Prince of Peace” means that he brings wholeness. His government will have no end, and it will rest on justice and righteousness.

Notice the phrase, “The zeal of the LORD of hosts will do this.” God himself is committed to accomplishing it. Yet the rest of chapter 9 and chapter 10 describe the judgment that comes first. Assyria is God’s axe, used to chop down his own people, but then judged for its pride. The tool that boasts against its maker will be broken. “Shall the axe boast over him who hews with it?”

Chapter 11 returns to hope. The Assyrian army is described as a forest cut down, but a shoot comes from the stump of Jesse. The picture is of a royal family reduced to a stump after the fall of David’s line, and yet life springs from it. Upon him rests the Spirit in sevenfold fullness. He judges the poor with righteousness. And his reign restores creation itself: the wolf with the lamb, the leopard with the young goat, a child leading them. The cause is that “the earth will be full of the knowledge of the LORD as the waters cover the sea.”

Chapter 12 ends the section with a song. “Behold, God is my salvation; I will trust, and will not be afraid.” “With joy you will draw water from the wells of salvation.” The proper response to such promises is song.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 4:12-16 quotes Isaiah 9:1-2 and says that Jesus began his ministry in Galilee. Luke 1:32-33 echoes Isaiah 9:7 in the angel’s announcement to Mary. Revelation 5:5 calls Jesus the Root of David, and Romans 15:12 quotes Isaiah 11:10. At his baptism the Spirit rested on Jesus (Matthew 3:16). Romans 8:19-21 speaks of creation itself being set free. John 7:37-38 recalls the wells of salvation.

STEP 6

Application

Read Isaiah 9:6 aloud and pause on each of the four names. Which one do you most need today?

Think about a dark place in your life or community. Pray for light to shine there.

Sing or read Isaiah 12:2 as a prayer of trust.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the light that has dawned on you.

Praise the child as Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.

Ask him to bring his peace where you are.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 56

"For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace."

ISAIAH 9:6

DAY 388 · WEEK 56

Isaiah 13:1-17:14

Oracles against Babylon, Assyria, Philistia, Moab [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 86 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 13:1-17:14. This is a survey day. These chapters contain oracles against Babylon, Assyria, Philistia, Moab, Damascus, and others. Do not worry about every name. Read for the main point: God rules over all the nations.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah's message so far has been to Judah. Now he turns outward. The oracles against the nations make up chapters 13 to 23, and they teach that the God of Israel is not just a tribal deity. He is the judge of all the earth. Babylon and Assyria, the great powers of the day, are included. These oracles also served a purpose for Judah: they showed that trusting in alliances with the nations was foolish, since all of them are under God's judgment.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The oracle concerning Babylon which Isaiah the son of Amoz saw" (13:1).
2. "Behold, the day of the LORD comes, cruel, with wrath and fierce anger, to make the land a desolation" (13:9).
3. "I will punish the world for its evil, and the wicked for their iniquity; I will put an end to the pomp of the arrogant" (13:11).
4. "How you are fallen from heaven, O Day Star, son of Dawn! ... You said in your heart, I will ascend to heaven" (14:12-13).
5. "This is the purpose that is purposed concerning the whole earth, and this is the hand that is stretched out over all the nations" (14:26).
6. "For the LORD has had compassion on Jacob and will again choose Israel" (14:1).

7. “My heart cries out for Moab” (15:5).
8. “In that day man will look to his Maker, and his eyes will look on the Holy One of Israel” (17:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first oracle is against Babylon, which at this time was not yet the dominant power. Isaiah looks ahead to its rise and fall. The day of the LORD is a day of judgment on pride, “to put an end to the pomp of the arrogant.” Babylon is described as “the glory of kingdoms,” yet it will be like Sodom and Gomorrah, a place for desert animals. In the Bible, Babylon becomes a symbol of human pride and organized rebellion against God, from the tower of Babel to the book of Revelation.

The taunt against the king of Babylon in chapter 14 is one of the most striking passages in Isaiah. The king is addressed as “Day Star, son of Dawn,” who tried to ascend to heaven and set his throne above the stars of God. He is brought down to Sheol. Christian tradition has often read this passage as describing Satan’s fall, and the pattern of pride that leads to a fall certainly applies. In its original setting, it is a mocking song about a tyrant whose arrogance ended in the grave. Either way, the lesson is the same. Whoever exalts himself will be humbled.

Notice that in the middle of the judgment, Isaiah describes God’s compassion on Jacob. God’s justice toward the nations is connected to his faithfulness to his people. And the purpose is “purposed concerning the whole earth.” History is not random. God has a plan, and none can annul it.

Even in the oracle against Moab, Isaiah weeps. “My heart cries out for Moab.” The prophet is not gleeful about judgment. And Damascus, Ephraim, and the others show the same: trust in human alliances will fail. In the day of judgment, people will “look to their Maker.” Some will turn to him.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven” (Luke 10:18). Revelation 18 describes the fall of Babylon the great, and Revelation 17 shows its pride. Daniel 4:30-37 shows Nebuchadnezzar humbled. James 4:6 says, “God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble.” Acts 17:26-27 says God made every nation and determined their times and boundaries. Ezekiel 33:11 shows that God takes no pleasure in the death of the wicked.

STEP 6

Application

Look at the news and remember that God rules the nations. Pray for a nation that is in turmoil.

Examine yourself for the pride expressed in “I will ascend.” Where do you want to be on top?

Weep for someone you might be tempted to judge, as Isaiah did for Moab.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as ruler of all nations.
- Ask him to humble pride in you.
- Pray for a nation in turmoil.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 56

“For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.”

ISAIAH 9:6

DAY 389 · WEEK 56

Isaiah 18:1-23:18

Oracles against the nations continue [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 105 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 18:1-23:18. This is another survey day. The oracles continue against Cush, Egypt, Babylon, Edom, Arabia, Jerusalem, and Tyre. Look for the repeated message: do not put your trust in the nations.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The oracles against the nations continue. Judah was tempted to look to Egypt and Cush (Ethiopia) for protection against Assyria, and Isaiah repeatedly warns against it. One of the strangest passages in the book appears in chapter 20, where Isaiah walks naked and barefoot for three years as a sign of what would happen to Egypt and Cush. Chapter 22 turns the oracles back toward Jerusalem itself.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “In that time a present will be brought to the LORD of hosts from a people tall and smooth-skinned” (18:7).
2. “The LORD will strike Egypt, striking and healing, and they will return to the LORD, and he will listen to their pleas” (19:22).
3. “Blessed be Egypt my people, and Assyria the work of my hands, and Israel my inheritance” (19:25).
4. “Thus shall it be with the nations in which we hoped… and how shall we escape?” (20:6).
5. “Watchman, what time of the night?” (21:11).
6. “You were not looking to him who did it, or have regard for him who planned it long ago” (22:11).

7. “And I will place on his shoulder the key of the house of David” (22:22).
8. “Her merchandise and her wages will be holy to the LORD” (23:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The oracles of these chapters appear dry, but they carry a thread of astonishing hope. Egypt, the old oppressor of Israel, will be struck by the LORD and then healed. In chapter 19, there is a vision of a day when Egypt will speak the language of Canaan, build an altar to the LORD, and cry out to him. He will send them a savior, and they will know him. And then the climax: “Blessed be Egypt my people, and Assyria the work of my hands, and Israel my inheritance.” Three nations, former enemies, become a blessing in the midst of the earth. The gospel of God’s mercy for the nations is already in the Old Testament.

The oracle of chapter 20 is bizarre but purposeful. Isaiah’s three years of walking naked and barefoot is a sermon without words: this is how the Egyptians and Ethiopians will be led away by Assyria. Those who relied on them will say, “Where can we escape?” It was designed to make Judah afraid of putting hope in the wrong place.

Chapter 22 is the oracle about Jerusalem, “the valley of vision.” The city celebrates when it should mourn. People prepare their defenses, store water, fortify the walls, and count houses, but “you did not look to him who did it.” They prepared everything but did not seek God. The result is a dreadful motto: “Let us eat and drink, for tomorrow we die.” Paul quotes it in 1 Corinthians 15:32. The chapter also contains the story of Shebna, a proud steward replaced by Eliakim, who receives “the key of the house of David.” He can open, and none can shut.

The last oracle, against Tyre, ends with a surprise: her profits will be set apart for the LORD. The nations are not simply doomed. Some are redeemed.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 3:7 speaks of Christ as the one “who has the key of David, who opens and no one will shut.” Acts 8:26-40 records an Ethiopian official coming to faith. Ephesians 2:13-14 says that those who were far off have been brought near. Galatians 3:8 says the gospel was preached beforehand to Abraham: “In you shall all the nations be blessed.” Revelation 21:24 pictures the nations bringing their glory into the city.

STEP 6

Application

Where are you trusting in something other than God for security: a job, savings, relationships, a plan?

Pray for a nation or group you would not usually pray for, including those who have been enemies.

Remember that the keys of the kingdom are in the hands of Jesus, and bring a closed door to him in prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you look to Egypt, to people or things, for help.
- Pray for the nations to be brought into his kingdom.
- Thank him that his plan stands.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 56

"For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace."

ISAIAH 9:6

DAY 390 · WEEK 56

Psalm 75

At the set time I will judge with equity

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 75. It is a short psalm in which God speaks about his appointed time to judge. Notice how the psalm moves between praise, a divine oracle, and the psalmist's response.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 75 is a psalm of Asaph, set to the tune "Do Not Destroy." It likely belongs to the time of the Assyrian crisis. The people are surrounded by arrogant powers, and the question is when God will act. The answer comes in a divine oracle: God has an appointed time, and he will judge with equity. It is a good companion to the oracles against the nations you have just read.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "We give thanks to you, O God; we give thanks, for your name is near" (v. 1).
2. "At the set time that I appoint I will judge with equity" (v. 2).
3. "When the earth totters, and all its inhabitants, it is I who keep steady its pillars" (v. 3).
4. "I say to the boastful, Do not boast, and to the wicked, Do not lift up your horn" (v. 4).
5. "Do not lift up your horn on high, or speak with haughty neck" (v. 5).
6. "For not from the east or from the west and not from the wilderness comes lifting up" (v. 6).
7. "But it is God who executes judgment, putting down one and lifting up another" (v. 7).
8. "All the horns of the wicked I will cut off, but the horns of the righteous shall be lifted up" (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with thanks. The strange thing is that the thanks come before the judgment. The psalmist is confident that God is near, and he can give thanks in advance. This is the posture of faith. We thank God not only for what he has done but for what he is going to do.

Then God speaks: "At the set time that I appoint I will judge with equity." Two things are stressed. First, God has a schedule. Judgment is not rushed or delayed by accident. It will come at the right moment, when he decides. People often think that because judgment is delayed, it will never come. The psalm says it will. Second, God judges with equity. He does not act capriciously. His judgment is perfectly fair.

When the earth totters and the foundations seem to shake, God says it is he who steadies its pillars. In the Assyrian crisis, with kingdoms collapsing, the world seemed unstable. The psalm assures us that the stability of the world rests on God.

Then the oracle addresses the arrogant: do not boast, do not lift up your horn. The horn is a symbol of strength and pride. The proud think they can raise themselves. But "not from the east or from the west… comes lifting up." No human direction offers promotion. "It is God who executes judgment, putting down one and lifting up another." Everything depends on him.

The cup in verse 8 is a cup of wrath. The wicked of the earth will drink it to the dregs. Against that, the psalmist says: "I will declare it forever; I will sing praises to the God of Jacob." The final verse contrasts the horns of the wicked, which will be cut off, with the horns of the righteous, which will be lifted up.

STEP 5

Connection

Mary's song says, "He has brought down the mighty from their thrones and exalted those of humble estate" (Luke 1:52). Jesus said that those who exalt themselves will be humbled, and those who humble themselves will be exalted (Luke 14:11). 1 Peter 5:6 says, "Humble yourselves, therefore, under the mighty hand of God so that at the proper time he may exalt you." Jesus drank the cup of God's wrath on the cross (Mark 14:36).

STEP 6

Application

If you are tempted to boast, remember that all lifting up comes from God.

If you are waiting for justice, trust God's set time, and give thanks in advance.

Pray for stability for those whose world is shaking.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God for being near.
- Ask him to keep you from boasting.
- Thank him that he judges with equity.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 56

"For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace."

ISAIAH 9:6

DAY 391 · WEEK 56

Psalm 76

In Judah God is known

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 76. It is a victory song for Zion, probably written after the Assyrian army was destroyed outside Jerusalem. Imagine the people singing it in the temple after the night the camp fell silent.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 76 is a psalm of Asaph. Its mention of "Salem" and "Zion" places it in Jerusalem, and its description of warriors who "found not use of their hands" fits what happened to Sennacherib's army in 2 Kings 19:35, when the angel of the LORD struck down 185,000 men in one night. You read this psalm once in Unit 8, where the focus was on God's presence. Here, hear it as the song after the Assyrian crisis.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In Judah God is known; his name is great in Israel" (v. 1).
2. "His abode has been established in Salem, his dwelling place in Zion" (v. 2).
3. "There he broke the flashing arrows, the shield, the sword, and the weapons of war" (v. 3).
4. "The stouthearted were stripped of their spoil; they sank into sleep; all the men of war were unable to use their hands" (v. 5).
5. "At your rebuke, O God of Jacob, both rider and horse lay stunned" (v. 6).
6. "But you, you are to be feared! Who can stand before you when once your anger is roused?" (v. 7).

7. “From the heavens you uttered judgment; the earth feared and was still, when God arose to establish judgment, to save all the humble of the earth” (vv. 8-9).

8. “Make vows to the LORD your God and perform them; let all around him bring gifts to him who is to be feared” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a claim. In Judah God is known. This is a statement about revelation. Other nations had their gods, but the LORD made himself known in a specific people and place. His dwelling is in Zion, and from there he reveals who he is.

The picture of verse 3 is a victory without a battle on Judah’s side. The arrows, the shield, the sword are broken “there,” at Jerusalem. The enemy soldiers were stripped of their spoil and sank into sleep, the sleep of death. The mighty are helpless. The psalm does not mention Judah’s army. It was God’s victory. “At your rebuke… both rider and horse lay stunned.” In the Assyrian camp, with their chariots and horsemen, nothing was left.

The turning point is the question in verse 7: “Who can stand before you when once your anger is roused?” It is not a question about the Assyrian army only. It is a question for everyone. No one can stand before God’s anger. And yet, the same verse of judgment has a purpose: “to save all the humble of the earth.” God’s judgment is a rescue for those who are oppressed. The wrath of man shall praise him, the psalm says, and the survivors of wrath will be restrained.

The psalm then calls for a response. Make vows and keep them. Bring gifts to the one to be feared. The proper response to a God who is awesome is worship and fulfilling our promises to him. And the final line is a warning to the powerful: “He cuts off the spirit of princes; he is to be feared by the kings of the earth.”

For Hezekiah and the people of Jerusalem, this psalm was a testimony. The God of whom Isaiah spoke had done what he said.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said that the gates of hell will not prevail against his church (Matthew 16:18). Revelation 19:11-16 shows a victorious king on a white horse. Colossians 2:15 says Christ disarmed the rulers and authorities and made a public spectacle of them. Zephaniah 3:17 says the LORD is mighty to save. Romans 12:1 invites us to make our own offering. Hebrews 12:28-29 says our God is a consuming fire and calls for reverence.

STEP 6

Application

Think about a situation in which you were rescued without doing anything. Give thanks for it.

Keep a vow you have made to God and neglected.

Take comfort that God saves “all the humble of the earth.” Choose humility today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Stand in awe of God’s name and power.

Thank him for saving the humble.

Tell him a vow you want to keep.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 56

“For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.”

ISAIAH 9:6

DAY 392 · WEEK 56

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Isaiah 9:6 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace."

ISAIAH 9:6

REST

Meditation

This verse is among the best loved in the Bible, and it is easy to hear it as only a Christmas carol. Read it today as Isaiah's first hearers did, in a time of fear and darkness.

"For to us a child is born." The Messiah will be truly human, born into the world as every child is. "To us a son is given." He is a gift. The first phrase says what he is, a real child. The second says where he comes from, a gift from God. He is both fully one of us and given to us from above.

"The government shall be upon his shoulder." A child with the weight of the world's government on his shoulder. In the ancient world, the key or the robe of office was worn on the shoulder. The one who rules is the child. It is a paradox that the New Testament unfolds, a king born in a manger, who rules from a cross.

Then four names. “Wonderful Counselor” means that he has wisdom beyond ours, and that he never gives bad advice. “Mighty God” means that he is not merely human. He is God, the divine warrior. “Everlasting Father” means that he cares for his people with a father’s love and does so forever. “Prince of Peace” means that he is the source of wholeness, and the reconciler between God and man.

Say the names slowly. Choose one that you most need today. If you are confused, he is your Counselor. If you are afraid, he is the Mighty God. If you feel alone, he is the Everlasting Father. If you are anxious or divided, he is your Prince of Peace.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the oracles of Isaiah’s first section. You read the great promises of the Messiah: the light in Galilee, the child born to us, the shoot from Jesse’s stump, and the kingdom where the earth is filled with the knowledge of the LORD. You took a doctrinal pause on the holiness of God, linking Isaiah’s vision to Peter’s call to be holy. You surveyed the oracles against Babylon, Philistia, Moab, Egypt, Jerusalem, and Tyre, and saw that God rules all the nations and even promises to bless Egypt and Assyria. And you read two psalms of the Assyrian crisis: Psalm 75, on God’s set time to judge, and Psalm 76, a victory song for Zion. The week taught that God is holy, that he rules history, and that he sends a child who will be the Prince of Peace.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

God’s holiness means that he is set apart and morally pure. How does that change the way you think of coming to him?

Isaiah 9:6 gives four names for the coming king. Which of these do you most need Jesus to be for you this week, and why?

The oracles against the nations show that God rules all of history. What situation in the world or your own life is easier to face when you remember this?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the child born and the son given.

Pray that his government and peace would grow in your life.

Rest in him as Prince of Peace.

DAY 393 · WEEK 57

Psalm 83

O God, do not keep silence

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 83. It is a prayer against a coalition of enemy nations that plot to wipe Israel off the map. Notice what the psalmist finally asks God to do to the enemies, and why.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 83 is a song of Asaph. It lists ten nations that have conspired against Israel: Edom, the Ishmaelites, Moab, the Hagrites, Gebal, Ammon, Amalek, Philistia, Tyre, and Assyria. The occasion may be one of the great coalitions in Judah's history, such as the one in 2 Chronicles 20. It follows the oracles against the nations: those who plot against God's people will answer to God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O God, do not keep silence; do not hold your peace or be still, O God!" (v. 1).
2. "For behold, your enemies make an uproar; those who hate you have raised their heads" (v. 2).
3. "They lay crafty plans against your people; they consult together against your treasured ones" (v. 3).
4. "They say, Come, let us wipe them out as a nation; let the name of Israel be remembered no more!" (v. 4).
5. "For they conspire with one accord; against you they make a covenant" (v. 5).
6. "Do to them as you did to Midian, as to Sisera and Jabin at the river Kishon" (v. 9).
7. "Fill their faces with shame, that they may seek your name, O LORD" (v. 16).

8 “That they may know that you alone, whose name is the LORD, are the Most High over all the earth” (v. 18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with an urgent plea that God would not be silent. The psalmist feels that God is quiet while the enemies are loud. This is the common experience of the people of God: the wicked are noisy and active, and God seems to be still. The prayer asks God to speak and act.

The enemies’ plan is genocide. “Come, let us wipe them out as a nation; let the name of Israel be remembered no more!” It is a conspiracy to erase God’s people. Notice the key line in verse 5: “Against you they make a covenant.” The psalmist sees that the attack on Israel is an attack on God. The people are God’s treasured ones, and to threaten them is to threaten him. This is the same logic as Saul on the road to Damascus, who was asked, “Why are you persecuting me?”

The psalmist then recalls past victories: Midian, Sisera, Jabin, Oreb and Zeeb. These were not won by Israel’s strength but by God’s intervention. The memory of past deliverance is the ground of present prayer.

The prayer for judgment uses imagery of fire, wind, and storms: let them be like tumbleweed, like chaff before the wind, like a forest in flames. But look at the purpose. “Fill their faces with shame, that they may seek your name, O LORD.” The aim is not only destruction but conversion. The psalmist wants the enemies to be humbled so that they will seek God. And the final goal is universal: “that they may know that you alone, whose name is the LORD, are the Most High over all the earth.”

This is the true motive of all faithful prayer for justice: the glory of God and the knowing of his name across the earth.

STEP 5

Connection

In Acts 9:4, Jesus asked Saul, “Why are you persecuting me?” Saul, once an enemy, became an apostle, just as the psalm hopes enemies may seek the LORD’s name. Matthew 5:44 commands us to love our enemies and pray for those who persecute us. Philippians 2:10-11 says that every knee will bow and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father. Revelation 11:15 says the kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for those who oppose the church, that they would seek the name of the LORD.

Remember a past deliverance and give thanks. Let it support a present prayer.

Pray for the persecuted church by name, if you know a country or region.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what troubles his people today.
- Ask him to act, and to bring his enemies to seek his name.
- Remember what he has done in the past.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 57

"You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you."

ISAIAH 26:3

DAY 394 · WEEK 57

Isaiah 24:1-27:13

The Isaiah Apocalypse, cosmic judgment and salvation

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 87 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 24:1-27:13. These chapters are called the Isaiah Apocalypse. They look beyond the Assyrian crisis to the end of history. Read for the big picture: the whole earth judged, and a feast on the mountain of the LORD.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the oracles against individual nations, Isaiah steps back and describes judgment on the whole earth. The language is cosmic, with the earth laid waste, the heavens shaken, and the moon confounded. And in the midst of it, there are songs of praise, a banquet for all peoples, and the promise that death itself will be swallowed up. Though these chapters are difficult, they contain some of the most beautiful promises in the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Behold, the LORD will empty the earth and make it desolate, and he will twist its surface and scatter its inhabitants” (24:1).
2. “The earth lies defiled under its inhabitants; for they have transgressed the laws, violated the statutes, broken the everlasting covenant” (24:5).
3. “O LORD, you are my God; I will exalt you; I will praise your name, for you have done wonderful things” (25:1).
4. “On this mountain the LORD of hosts will make for all peoples a feast of rich food, a feast of well-aged wine” (25:6).
5. “He will swallow up death forever; and the Lord GOD will wipe away tears from all faces” (25:8).

6. “You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you” (26:3).
7. “Your dead shall live; their bodies shall rise” (26:19).
8. “In that day the LORD with his hard and great and strong sword will punish Leviathan” (27:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 24 describes universal judgment. It falls on everyone: priest and people, master and servant, buyer and seller. The cause is that humanity has broken “the everlasting covenant.” This is not just Israel’s sin but the sin of the whole human race, going back to Adam and Noah. The earth itself suffers under the guilt of its inhabitants.

Yet scattered through the judgment are glimpses of praise. From the ends of the earth, songs of glory to the Righteous One are heard. And then in chapter 25, an extended song of thanks. God has been a stronghold to the poor and needy, a shelter from the storm, a shade from the heat. He has done wonderful things, plans formed of old, faithful and sure.

The heart of the Apocalypse is Isaiah 25:6-9. On the mountain of the LORD, a feast is prepared for all peoples. This is not for Israel alone. It is the banquet of the kingdom. And the shroud that covers all peoples will be destroyed. “He will swallow up death forever.” God himself will wipe away tears from all faces. The disgrace of his people will be removed. And the people will say, “This is our God; we have waited for him, that he might save us.” The sight of death’s defeat is the central hope of the Old Testament.

Chapter 26 is a song for the day of salvation, and it contains the verse for this week: “You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you.” A mind fixed on God is a mind at rest. And verse 19, “Your dead shall live; their bodies shall rise,” is one of the clearest statements of resurrection in the Old Testament. Chapter 27 ends with the vineyard of Isaiah 5 restored: “Israel shall blossom and put forth shoots and fill the whole world with fruit.”

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Isaiah 25:8 in 1 Corinthians 15:54: “Death is swallowed up in victory.” Revelation 21:4 echoes: “He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more.” Jesus told of the great banquet (Luke 14:15-24) and the wedding feast (Matthew 22:1-14). Revelation 19:9 speaks of the marriage supper of the Lamb. Philippians 4:7 speaks of the peace of God that guards our hearts and minds in Christ Jesus.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Isaiah 26:3 and practice it when you feel anxious.

Think about someone who has died in Christ, and take comfort from the promise of resurrection.

Remember the banquet. Invite someone this week to a meal as a small picture of the feast.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for the wonderful things he has done.

Thank him that he will swallow up death forever and wipe away tears.

Tell him what tears you are bringing him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 57

"You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you."

ISAIAH 26:3

DAY 395 · WEEK 57

Isaiah 28:1-30:33

Woes to Ephraim and Judah; “in quietness and trust”

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 82 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 28:1-30:33. These chapters are a series of woes aimed at the leaders of Israel and Judah. They are pointed and sometimes sarcastic. Look for the contrast between trusting in political schemes and “in quietness and trust.”

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

As the Assyrian threat grows, the leaders in Jerusalem begin to look to Egypt for a military alliance. Isaiah condemns the plan as a covenant with death. The woes of these chapters describe drunken priests, hypocritical worship, secret plans made without God, and people who tell the prophets to stop giving them hard truths. At the center is a beautiful word about the cornerstone that God lays in Zion.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Woe to the proud crown of the drunkards of Ephraim” (28:1).
2. “Precept upon precept, precept upon precept, line upon line, line upon line, here a little, there a little” (28:10).
3. “You have said, We have made a covenant with death, and with Sheol we have an agreement” (28:15).
4. “Behold, I am the one who has laid as a foundation in Zion, a stone, a tested stone, a precious cornerstone, of a sure foundation: Whoever believes will not be in haste” (28:16).
5. “This people draw near with their mouth and honor me with their lips, while their hearts are far from me” (29:13).

6. “Woe to those who hide deep from the LORD their counsel” (29:15).
7. “In returning and rest you shall be saved; in quietness and in trust shall be your strength. But you were unwilling” (30:15).
8. “Therefore the LORD waits to be gracious to you, and therefore he exalts himself to show mercy to you” (30:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 28 begins with the drunken leaders of the northern kingdom, whose fall is near. Then it turns to Jerusalem’s priests and prophets, who also stagger in drink. They mock Isaiah’s simple teaching as baby talk. “Precept upon precept” is how they hear it. God replies that if they will not listen to simple words, they will hear foreign tongues, the language of the Assyrian invaders.

The leaders have made a “covenant with death.” They think they have cheated the grave by political deals. But God lays a different foundation: a tested stone, a precious cornerstone, “a sure foundation.” Whoever believes in him will not be in a panic. The standard of justice will be the plumb line. In the face of political panic, the faithful rest on the stone God has laid.

Chapter 29 criticizes hollow religion. The people honor God with their lips but their hearts are far from him, and their fear of God is a tradition learned by rote. They think that God cannot see their schemes. Isaiah says the potter is not the same as the clay. God sees everything, and yet his plan includes a coming day when “the deaf shall hear the words of a book, and out of their gloom the eyes of the blind shall see.”

Chapter 30 is the center of this section. The people are sending envoys to Egypt, trusting in Pharaoh’s protection, and refusing to listen to the prophets. They say, “Do not prophesy to us what is right; speak to us smooth things.” God’s offer is simple: “In returning and rest you shall be saved; in quietness and in trust shall be your strength. But you were unwilling.” The most tragic words in the passage. Yet verse 18 is full of grace: “The LORD waits to be gracious to you.” The God who is angry is also the God who waits, and who will answer the cry for help.

STEP 5

Connection

Peter quotes Isaiah 28:16 in 1 Peter 2:6 and calls Christ the cornerstone. Paul quotes it in Romans 9:33 and 10:11. Jesus quotes Isaiah 29:13 in Mark 7:6-7. Paul quotes Isaiah 29:14 in 1 Corinthians 1:19. Hebrews 4:9-11 speaks of a Sabbath rest for the people of God. Psalm 46:10 says, “Be still, and know that I am God.” Matthew 11:28 offers rest to the weary.

STEP 6

Application

Practice “quietness and trust” for ten minutes today. Turn off every distraction and simply rest in God.

Ask yourself where you have made a “covenant with death,” a plan to avoid consequences or guarantee security without God.

Receive the truth that the LORD waits to be gracious to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the cornerstone he laid.
- Confess where you honor him with lips but not heart.
- Ask for quietness and trust.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 57

“You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you.”

ISAIAH 26:3

DAY 396 · WEEK 57

Isaiah 31:1-35:10

Woe to those who go to Egypt; the highway of holiness

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 31:1-35:10. The woes continue against reliance on Egypt, but then chapters 32 to 35 move toward a glorious future. Read chapter 35 slowly, as a picture of the transformed world.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The crisis with Assyria is at its height. Hezekiah's advisors continue to look to Egypt for horses and chariots. Isaiah warns them against it, and then describes a righteous king, a poured-out Spirit, a coming judgment on Edom, and the joyful return of the redeemed along "the highway of holiness." Chapters 34 and 35 close the first half of Isaiah with a stark contrast between judgment and joy.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Woe to those who go down to Egypt for help and rely on horses, who trust in chariots because they are many... but do not look to the Holy One of Israel" (31:1).
2. "The Egyptians are man, and not God, and their horses are flesh, and not spirit" (31:3).
3. "Behold, a king will reign in righteousness, and princes will rule in justice" (32:1).
4. "Until the Spirit is poured upon us from on high, and the wilderness becomes a fruitful field" (32:15).
5. "The effect of righteousness will be peace, and the result of righteousness, quietness and trust forever" (32:17).
6. "O LORD, be gracious to us; we wait for you" (33:2).

7. “For the LORD is our judge; the LORD is our lawgiver; the LORD is our king; he will save us” (33:22).

8. “And a highway shall be there, and it shall be called the Way of Holiness” (35:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The main sin of chapter 31 is stated plainly: trusting in horses and chariots rather than in the Holy One of Israel. Isaiah’s contrast is memorable: “The Egyptians are man, and not God, and their horses are flesh, and not spirit.” Whatever human power we trust in is limited by its own nature. The LORD of hosts will fight for Jerusalem like a lion over its prey or like birds hovering. He will protect and deliver.

Chapter 32 opens with a promise of a righteous king and a time when people will see clearly. It also speaks to the complacent women of the city, who will be shaken from their ease. But then, “until the Spirit is poured upon us from on high.” This is a promise of the Spirit’s coming and of a transformation of the land. The result is justice, righteousness, peace, and security. These flow from God’s Spirit.

Chapter 33 contains a prayer, “O LORD, be gracious to us; we wait for you,” and then the stunning reversal of the Assyrian threat. The enemy who dealt treacherously will be dealt with. Then the prophet asks who can live with the consuming fire, and answers: he who walks righteously and speaks uprightly. And the chapter ends with a great statement: “The LORD is our judge; the LORD is our lawgiver; the LORD is our king; he will save us.”

Chapter 34 is the dark side, a judgment on the nations, symbolized by Edom. And chapter 35 is the bright side. It is a poem of transformation. The desert blossoms. The weak hands are strengthened. The eyes of the blind are opened, the ears of the deaf unstopped, the lame leap like a deer, and the mute sing. A highway is built, the Way of Holiness. The unclean shall not pass over it, but the redeemed shall walk there. “The ransomed of the LORD shall return and come to Zion with singing; everlasting joy shall be upon their heads.” It is the vision of salvation as a return home.

STEP 5

Connection

When John the Baptist’s disciples asked Jesus if he was the one, Jesus answered by pointing to the signs of Isaiah 35: the blind see, the lame walk, the deaf hear (Matthew 11:2-5). Acts 2:17 quotes Joel on the pouring out of the Spirit, and Acts 2 shows its fulfillment. Jesus said, “I am the way” (John 14:6). Hebrews 12:12 echoes Isaiah 35:3. Revelation 21:4 says sorrow and sighing will flee away.

STEP 6

Application

Identify one “horse and chariot” you tend to trust, whether money, connections, or skills. Place it under God’s care.

Pray for the Spirit to be “poured out from on high” on your church and community.

Strengthen a weak hand this week by encouraging someone who is struggling.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess where you trust horses and chariots.

Ask God to pour out his Spirit on his people.

Thank him that he makes a highway of holiness for his redeemed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 57

“You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you.”

ISAIAH 26:3

DAY 397 · WEEK 57

Isaiah 36:1-37:38

The Assyrian crisis; Hezekiah's prayer; Sennacherib falls

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 36:1-37:38. This is the same story you read in 2 Kings 18-19, now from Isaiah's side. Notice what is added: the sharpness of the Assyrian propaganda, the detail of Hezekiah's prayer, and the poem that Isaiah speaks against Sennacherib.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah 36-39 is a historical interlude that connects the two halves of the book. It repeats and expands the account in 2 Kings, with an important addition in Isaiah 38. In 701 BC, Sennacherib besieged Jerusalem after capturing the other cities of Judah. He sent his field commander to demoralize the city. This is the pivotal event of the first half of Isaiah: will the nation trust in God or in the powers of the world?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "What is this trust of yours?" (36:4).
2. "Do not let Hezekiah deceive you, for he will not be able to deliver you" (36:14).
3. "Who among all the gods of these lands have delivered their lands out of my hand, that the LORD should deliver Jerusalem out of my hand?" (36:20).
4. "This day is a day of distress, of rebuke, and of disgrace" (37:3).
5. "O LORD of hosts, enthroned above the cherubim, you are the God, you alone, of all the kingdoms of the earth" (37:16).
6. "Incline your ear, O LORD, and hear; open your eyes, O LORD, and see" (37:17).
7. "Whom have you mocked and reviled? Against whom have you raised your voice?" (37:23).

8 “And the angel of the LORD went out and struck down 185,000 in the camp of the Assyrians” (37:36).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The field commander speaks like a skilled propagandist. He begins by undermining confidence in Egypt, then in Hezekiah, then in the LORD. He says that Hezekiah removed the altars of the LORD, which he distorts as an insult to God, though it was a reform. He claims that the LORD told him to attack Judah. And his final argument is the most dangerous: no god of any nation has saved it from Assyria, so why would the LORD? It places the LORD on the same level as the idols of the nations. It is a claim that God is no different from other gods, and it has to be answered.

Hezekiah’s response is quiet. The army is ordered not to answer. The king goes to the house of the LORD and sends for the prophet. Isaiah gives the first word: “Do not be afraid.” Then Sennacherib sends a second letter, and Hezekiah does the thing for which he is remembered. He spreads it out before the LORD. His prayer is a model. It begins with who God is: enthroned above the cherubim, the only God of all the kingdoms, the maker of heaven and earth. It describes the threat honestly. It makes a request: save us. And it states the purpose: “that all the kingdoms of the earth may know that you alone are the LORD.”

God’s answer through Isaiah is a poem of mockery against the proud king. “Whom have you mocked and reviled?” It was against the Holy One of Israel. The king thinks he has conquered by his own power, but God says, “Have you not heard that I determined it long ago?” Assyria was an instrument, and its pride is its downfall. God promises to put his hook in Sennacherib’s nose and turn him back the way he came.

That night the angel of the LORD strikes down 185,000 in the camp. In the morning, the army is dead. Sennacherib returns to Nineveh, and years later he is killed by his own sons while worshiping his god. The god he trusted could not protect him.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told his disciples to pray in his name and promised that the Father would give what they asked (John 16:23-24). Hebrews 4:16 invites us to the throne of grace. 2 Corinthians 10:4-5 says our weapons are not of the flesh but have divine power to destroy strongholds. Psalm 46 and Psalm 48, coming up, celebrate this deliverance. Revelation 12:11 says the saints conquer by the blood of the Lamb and the word of their testimony.

STEP 6

Application

Use Hezekiah's prayer as a pattern: begin with who God is, bring the problem honestly, make your request, and state your purpose.

When voices tell you that no one can help you, remember the 185,000.

Write down a problem and, as Hezekiah did, spread it before the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Spread before God what troubles you, as Hezekiah did.

Ask him to incline his ear and open his eyes.

Praise him as the God, you alone.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 57

"You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you."

ISAIAH 26:3

DAY 398 · WEEK 57

Isaiah 38:1-39:8

Hezekiah's illness and recovery; the Babylonian envoys

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 30 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 38:1-39:8. Hezekiah becomes ill, prays, and is given fifteen more years. Then he makes a mistake with the Babylonian envoys. Read the prayer of thanks in 38:9-20, and notice the sober ending.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the last section of the historical interlude. In about 703 BC, Hezekiah became deathly ill. The prophet told him to set his house in order, because he would die. The king turned his face to the wall and prayed. God heard and added fifteen years to his life. Then envoys arrived from Merodach-baladan of Babylon, ostensibly to congratulate him. The story serves as a hinge: the Assyrian threat is over, but the Babylonian one is coming.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Set your house in order, for you shall die, you shall not recover" (38:1).
2. "Then Hezekiah turned his face to the wall and prayed to the LORD" (38:2).
3. "Remember how I have walked before you in faithfulness and with a whole heart" (38:3).
4. "I have heard your prayer; I have seen your tears. Behold, I will add fifteen years to your life" (38:5).
5. "Behold, it was for my welfare that I had great bitterness; but in love you have delivered my life from the pit of destruction, for you have cast all my sins behind your back" (38:17).
6. "For Sheol does not thank you; death does not praise you" (38:18).

7. “And Hezekiah was pleased, and showed them his treasure house” (39:2).
8. “Days are coming, when all that is in your house… shall be carried to Babylon. Nothing shall be left” (39:6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The illness comes at the same time as the Assyrian threat, perhaps in the same year. For Hezekiah, the news that he would die meant more than personal loss. He had no son, and the Davidic line seemed at risk. He weeps bitterly and prays. His prayer is honest: remember how I have walked before you. It is not self-righteous but an appeal to the covenant relationship. And God answers. “I have heard your prayer; I have seen your tears.” He gives a sign: the shadow on the stairway goes backward ten steps.

Hezekiah’s psalm records his experience. He describes his life cut off like a weaver rolling up a cloth. He moans like a dove. And then comes the turning point in verse 17: “In love you have delivered my life from the pit of destruction, for you have cast all my sins behind your back.” It is one of the most beautiful phrases in the Bible about forgiveness. What was behind God’s back is out of his sight. And the king concludes that the living thank God: “The fathers make known to the children your faithfulness.” The purpose of his extra years is to praise and to pass faith on.

Then chapter 39 delivers the sad aftermath. When the envoys of Babylon come, Hezekiah is flattered and shows them everything in his house and in all his realm. It may have been vanity, or a political move to find allies against Assyria. Either way, he looked to a human power instead of to God. Isaiah’s rebuke is solemn: everything will go to Babylon, and some of your own sons will be eunuchs in the palace of the king of Babylon.

Hezekiah’s reply is the most unsettling part: “The word of the LORD that you have spoken is good. For there will be peace and security in my days.” He accepts the word but seems concerned only with his own lifetime. The man who cried out for his life does not cry out for his descendants. Even great believers can be weak in the face of success.

STEP 5

Connection

Micah 7:19 says God will cast all our sins into the depths of the sea, and Colossians 2:13-14 says Christ canceled the record of debt. Psalm 103:12 says he removes our transgressions as far as the east is from the west. James 5:14-16 teaches us to pray for the sick. 2 Timothy 4:7 shows Paul finishing the race well, a contrast with Hezekiah’s mixed ending. Jesus warns in Luke 12:15-21 about the rich man who thinks only of his own ease.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God for any season of extra time, health, or opportunity, and ask what he wants you to do with it.

Pray for the generation after you, as Hezekiah's psalm says: make known God's faithfulness to the children.

Ask whether you have shown your treasures to the world in pride. Return the glory to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for hearing your prayer and seeing your tears.
- Thank him for casting your sins behind his back.
- Ask him to keep you from pride in the good he gives.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 57

"You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you."

ISAIAH 26:3

DAY 399 · WEEK 57

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Isaiah 26:3 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you."

ISAIAH 26:3

REST

Meditation

This promise comes in the middle of Isaiah's apocalypse, a section about the shaking of the whole earth. It is a song of confidence for the day of salvation, sung in a time of upheaval. Peace is promised, and it is promised in the midst of unrest.

"You keep him in perfect peace." In Hebrew, the words are "peace, peace," shalom shalom. The double word indicates fullness, a peace that is complete. It is not the absence of trouble but wholeness: well-being in body, soul, and relationships. And the one who gives it is God. He keeps, or guards, the person. The word is used of a sentry on watch.

"Whose mind is stayed on you." The word "stayed" means supported, leaning, resting on something. The mind that is steadied by God is a mind that is propped up. It is a picture of leaning on God, as one leans on a strong staff. The mind in view is not only intellect but the whole inner life, our thoughts, imaginings, and desires. When the center of our attention is God, the heart is stable.

“Because he trusts in you.” The ground of the peace is trust. The man in this verse is not free of problems. He is anchored. Isaiah’s contrast is clear throughout this week’s reading: the people of Judah were anxious because they trusted in Egypt, in treaties, and in horses. The peace came to those who trusted in the LORD, like Hezekiah on the day he spread the letter before him.

Say this verse in times of worry and ask what you are leaning on. In Christ, the Prince of Peace has made peace for us through his blood. He now says, “Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you.”

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the middle chapters of Isaiah’s first half. You prayed Psalm 83 against a coalition of enemy nations and saw that the real aim is that they would know the LORD is the Most High. You read the Isaiah Apocalypse, with its picture of a feast on God’s mountain, the swallowing up of death, and the promise of resurrection. You read the woes against trusting in Egypt, and the beautiful invitation to “return and rest.” You saw the cornerstone laid in Zion and heard of the Way of Holiness. Then you followed the Assyrian crisis through Isaiah’s eyes: Hezekiah spreading the letter before the LORD, the angel striking the camp, and the king’s illness, his healing, and his misstep with Babylon. The week taught that peace belongs to the mind that is stayed on God, and that those who trust in worldly power will be disappointed.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Isaiah calls us to “quietness and trust” rather than frantic human schemes. Where do you need to stop striving and rest in God?

Isaiah 25:8 promises that God will swallow up death forever and wipe away tears. How does this promise speak to your own grief or fear?

Hezekiah faithfully prayed in a crisis but was careless in success. In what area of your life is prosperity a bigger test than trouble?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you in perfect peace with your mind stayed on him.

Thank Christ for swallowing up death in victory.

Rest in quietness and trust.

DAY 400 · WEEK 58

Psalm 46

God is our refuge, Hezekiah's psalm

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 46. You have read it before, but read it now as the song Jerusalem sang after the night the Assyrian army fell. Notice the river, the refrain, and the command in verse 10.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 46 is a song of the sons of Korah. Many readers connect it to the deliverance of Jerusalem from Sennacherib, which you have just read. A city with no great river, Jerusalem is given a river in this psalm, a stream whose waters make glad the city of God. Martin Luther's hymn "A Mighty Fortress Is Our God" was inspired by it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble" (v. 1).
2. "Therefore we will not fear though the earth gives way, though the mountains be moved into the heart of the sea" (v. 2).
3. "There is a river whose streams make glad the city of God, the holy habitation of the Most High" (v. 4).
4. "God is in the midst of her; she shall not be moved; God will help her when morning dawns" (v. 5).
5. "The nations rage, the kingdoms totter; he utters his voice, the earth melts" (v. 6).
6. "The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress" (v. 7).
7. "He makes wars cease to the end of the earth; he breaks the bow and shatters the spear" (v. 9).

8 “Be still, and know that I am God. I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted in the earth!” (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm has three stanzas, each ending with a refrain, though the refrain is missing from the first stanza in our texts. The first describes the cosmos in chaos: earth giving way, mountains slipping into the sea, waters roaring. These are pictures of the greatest disaster the ancient mind could imagine. And the response is: “We will not fear.” The reason is not that the danger is small, but that God is a refuge, a very present help.

The second stanza turns to the city. In contrast to the roaring sea is a quiet river. The sea in ancient thought was a symbol of chaos, but Jerusalem has a stream that makes glad the city of God. This is a picture of God’s presence that gives life. And “God will help her when morning dawns.” Recall the 185,000 who lay dead in the morning. The help came at daybreak. The nations rage, but a single word from him melts the earth. The refrain says: “The LORD of hosts is with us.” It is the name Immanuel in the language of the psalms.

The third stanza invites us to look: “Come, behold the works of the LORD.” He makes wars cease, breaks the bow, shatters the spear, burns the chariots. What does that look like? It looks like an empty Assyrian camp.

Then the voice of God himself: “Be still, and know that I am God.” This is not a gentle suggestion to relax, though it may include that. The Hebrew word means “cease striving.” It is addressed to the nations as well as to Israel. Stop fighting, and know who is God. In Hezekiah’s case, the king was told to be quiet and the army to be silent. God did the fighting. The call to stillness is a call to trust, to stop relying on our own efforts and to rest in the one who is exalted among the nations.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus calmed the sea with a word (Mark 4:39), showing that he is the one who rules the chaotic waters. Romans 8:31 asks, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” Revelation 22:1 describes a river of the water of life flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb, the true fulfillment of the river of the city of God. Hebrews 12:28 says we receive a kingdom that cannot be shaken. Matthew 28:20 echoes: “I am with you always.”

STEP 6

Application

Say the refrain, “The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress,” every time you feel afraid today.

Practice verse 10. Sit in stillness for five minutes and simply know that he is God.

Think of a “morning” when God helped you after a long night. Thank him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what in your life feels like the earth giving way.
- Thank him that he is a very present help.
- Be still before him for a moment.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 58

“But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint.”

ISAIAH 40:31

DAY 401 · WEEK 58

Psalm 48

Walk about Zion, the city of God is secure

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 48. It is a song celebrating Jerusalem, "the city of our God." Imagine walking around the walls and counting the towers, as the psalm invites you to do.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 48 is a song of the sons of Korah. It follows Psalm 46 in this unit and in its original collection. The kings of the earth gathered against Zion, saw it, and fled in panic. It is the song of a city that has been delivered. You read it in Unit 9 as a song about the city of David. Today read it as the song of a city that has seen the Assyrian army vanish.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Great is the LORD and greatly to be praised in the city of our God! His holy mountain, beautiful in elevation, is the joy of all the earth" (vv. 1-2).
2. "Within her citadels God has made himself known as a fortress" (v. 3).
3. "For behold, the kings assembled; they came on together" (v. 4).
4. "As soon as they saw it, they were astounded; they were in panic; they took to flight" (v. 5).
5. "As we have heard, so have we seen in the city of the LORD of hosts" (v. 8).
6. "We have thought on your steadfast love, O God, in the midst of your temple" (v. 9).
7. "Walk about Zion, go around her, number her towers, consider well her ramparts, go through her citadels" (vv. 12-13).
8. "That you may tell the next generation that this is God, our God forever and ever. He will guide us forever" (vv. 13-14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with praise to the LORD and then to his city. The beauty of Zion is not the city for its own sake, but because of the God who lives there. The mountain is "the joy of all the earth," and "the city of the great King." In the ancient world, a city was only as good as its god. The psalmist insists that Jerusalem's strength comes from its God.

The account of the enemies in verses 4 to 7 is brief and almost comic. The kings gathered, they came together, they saw, they were astounded, they fled. It is like a wave dissolving. Like "ships of Tarshish shattered by an east wind." This is the same truth as Psalm 46 and Psalm 76: God defends his city.

Verse 9 is the center of the psalm. After the military story, the psalmist turns to the temple. "We have thought on your steadfast love, O God, in the midst of your temple." The greatest thing about the deliverance is not the defeat of enemies but what it reveals about God's covenant love. The people reflect on it in worship.

Then comes a strange invitation: "Walk about Zion, go around her, number her towers." Walk the walls. Count what is still there. After a great threat, check that everything is intact. And the purpose: "that you may tell the next generation that this is God." This is an educational walk. The visible city teaches children about God's faithfulness. The final verse is a confession: "This is God, our God forever and ever. He will guide us forever." The Hebrew can even be read "guide us beyond death."

The psalm reminds us to remember what God has done and to pass it on.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 5:35 calls Jerusalem "the city of the great King." Hebrews 12:22 says that believers have come "to Mount Zion and to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem." Revelation 21:2 describes the new Jerusalem coming down from heaven, and verse 23 says it has no need of sun or moon, for the glory of God is its light. Matthew 16:18 says that the gates of hell will not prevail against the church. Deuteronomy 6:7 commands us to tell the next generation.

STEP 6

Application

Take a "walk about Zion." List ten things God has done for your church or family, and number them like towers.

Tell a child, a new believer, or a friend one story of God's faithfulness this week.

Think on God's steadfast love, as the psalm says, during a time of worship.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for the security of his city.
- Tell him what you have thought on of his steadfast love.
- Ask him to guide you forever.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 58

"But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint."

ISAIAH 40:31

DAY 402 · WEEK 58

Isaiah 40:1-42:25

"Comfort my people"; the Servant introduced

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 89 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 40:1-42:25. The second half of Isaiah begins here. The mood shifts from judgment to comfort. Read chapter 40 slowly, and listen for the voice crying in the wilderness.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah 40 opens the second half of the book. Chapters 40 to 55 speak to a people who, in the prophet's vision, are in exile in Babylon, as Isaiah 39 foretold. The message is "Comfort, comfort my people." God is going to bring them back. These chapters present the incomparable God, his Servant, and his plan to redeem. They are some of the most beautiful and doctrinally rich in the Old Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Comfort, comfort my people, says your God. Speak tenderly to Jerusalem" (40:1-2).
2. "A voice cries: In the wilderness prepare the way of the LORD" (40:3).
3. "The grass withers, the flower fades, but the word of our God will stand forever" (40:8).
4. "Behold your God! ... He will tend his flock like a shepherd; he will gather the lambs in his arms" (40:9, 11).
5. "To whom then will you compare me, that I should be like him? says the Holy One" (40:25).
6. "They who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles" (40:31).

7. “Behold my servant, whom I uphold, my chosen, in whom my soul delights; I have put my Spirit upon him; he will bring forth justice to the nations” (42:1).

8. “A bruised reed he will not break, and a faintly burning wick he will not quench” (42:3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Isaiah 40 begins with a double command: “Comfort, comfort my people.” After the long section of judgment, God speaks tenderly. The warfare is ended, the iniquity pardoned. The people have received double for their sins, which means that their punishment is complete. A voice cries out for a highway to be built for the LORD in the wilderness. This is the announcement of God’s own return to his people.

The chapter next deals with the reasons for trust. First, God’s word stands forever, though human strength is like grass. Second, God is a shepherd who carries the lambs in his arms and gently leads those that are with young. Third, God is incomparable. He measured the waters in the hollow of his hand. The nations are like a drop from a bucket. The idols are made by craftsmen who nail them in place so they do not fall. Those who sit in exile feel forgotten, but God never grows weary. He gives power to the faint and strengthens the weak. Those who wait for him renew their strength.

Chapter 41 continues with God’s courtroom challenge to the idols and the nations. “Fear not, for I am with you; be not dismayed, for I am your God.” To Israel, called “worm Jacob,” he says that he is their redeemer, the Holy One of Israel.

Then in chapter 42 appears the first of the Servant Songs. “Behold my servant.” He is chosen, upheld, and endowed with God’s Spirit. His mission is to bring justice to the nations, not with a loud voice but with gentleness. “A bruised reed he will not break.” The Servant does not crush the weak. He will not grow faint or be discouraged until he has established justice in the earth. And the coastlands wait for his law.

The Servant is a mystery in Isaiah, and the question of who he is will keep returning. In this song, he is presented as the one who will bring God’s justice, with compassion for the weak.

STEP 5

Connection

All four Gospels apply Isaiah 40:3 to John the Baptist (Matthew 3:3; Mark 1:2-3; Luke 3:4-6; John 1:23). Matthew 12:15-21 quotes Isaiah 42:1-4 and applies it to Jesus. At his baptism, the Father’s voice echoed this, “my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased” (Matthew 3:17). 1 Peter 1:24-25 quotes Isaiah 40:6-8. John 10:11 shows Jesus as the good shepherd. Matthew 11:28-30 reveals his gentleness.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Isaiah 40:31, and apply it to an area where you are weary.

Think of someone who feels like a bruised reed. Be gentle with them this week.

Spend time meditating on the greatness of God in Isaiah 40:12-26, and let it shrink your problems.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to comfort his people, including you.

Ask him to prepare the way in your heart.

Thank him for the shepherd who carries the lambs.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 58

"But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint."

ISAIAH 40:31

DAY 403 · WEEK 58

Isaiah 43:1-45:25

You are mine; the only God; Cyrus named

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 43:1-45:25. God declares that he is the only God, he promises to redeem Israel, and he names Cyrus, a pagan king, as his instrument more than a century before he was born. Read with attention to the repeated “I am the LORD.”

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The exiles in Babylon thought that their God had been defeated by the gods of Babylon. Isaiah answers that God is not only sovereign but alone. The chapters here contain some of the strongest statements of monotheism in the Bible. They also contain the astonishing prophecy that Cyrus of Persia, who conquered Babylon in 539 BC, would be God’s shepherd to free his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Fear not, for I have redeemed you; I have called you by name, you are mine” (43:1).
2. “When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and through the rivers, they shall not overwhelm you” (43:2).
3. “I, I am the LORD, and besides me there is no savior” (43:11).
4. “Behold, I am doing a new thing; now it springs forth, do you not perceive it?” (43:19).
5. “I, I am he who blots out your transgressions for my own sake, and I will not remember your sins” (43:25).
6. “Before me no god was formed, nor shall there be any after me” (43:10).
7. “Who says of Cyrus, He is my shepherd, and he shall fulfill all my purpose” (44:28).

8 “Turn to me and be saved, all the ends of the earth! For I am God, and there is no other” (45:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 43 opens with “But now.” After the discipline of exile, God speaks. “Fear not, for I have redeemed you; I have called you by name, you are mine.” Notice the order: redemption first, then the claim. Israel is his because he bought them. Then the promises: through the waters, the rivers, the fire. These echo the sea and the Jordan. He will gather them from the ends of the earth.

God then argues against the idols. The nations are summoned to a court. Who among them declared the things that would happen? Israel is God’s witness: “You are my witnesses… and my servant whom I have chosen.” There is only one God and one Savior. The strongest part comes next. Though Israel has not called on him, wearied him with sins, and burdened him with iniquities, “I, I am he who blots out your transgressions for my own sake, and I will not remember your sins.” Forgiveness comes from God’s own initiative, not from Israel’s merit.

Chapter 44 contains a famous satire on idolatry. A man cuts down a tree, burns half for warming himself and cooking, and carves the rest into a god and bows down to it. “Deliver me, for you are my god!” Isaiah exposes the foolishness: it is a lie in his right hand. In contrast, the LORD says, “I formed you; you are my servant; O Israel, I will not forget you.”

At the end of chapter 44 and in chapter 45, Cyrus is named. God calls him “my shepherd” and “his anointed.” A pagan king who does not know the LORD is used for God’s purposes. This shows that God is sovereign over history, even over those who do not acknowledge him. God’s purpose is that people “may know, from the rising of the sun and from the west, that there is none besides me.”

The invitation at the end of chapter 45 is a gospel call: “Turn to me and be saved, all the ends of the earth!” One day every knee will bow.

STEP 5

Connection

Philippians 2:10-11 quotes Isaiah 45:23: every knee will bow and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord. Revelation 2:17 and John 10:3 echo God’s calling us by name. Acts 4:12 says there is salvation in no one else. Hebrews 8:12 says that God will remember our sins no more. 2 Corinthians 5:17 speaks of the new creation: “the old has passed away; behold, the new has come.” Romans 9:20-21 draws on the potter and clay imagery of Isaiah 45:9.

STEP 6

Application

Say aloud Isaiah 43:1 as a statement about you: “I have called you by name, you are mine.”

Notice a “new thing” that God may be doing in your life. Ask for eyes to see it.

Reflect on “Cyrus.” How has God used people who do not know him to serve you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are called by name and are his.

Thank him that he is with you in the waters.

Thank him for blotting out your transgressions.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 58

“But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint.”

ISAIAH 40:31

DAY 404 · WEEK 58

Psalm 86

I am poor and needy; you are good and forgiving

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 86. It is a prayer of David for help, based entirely on God's goodness, not on David's merit. Notice how many times David calls himself God's servant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 86 is the only psalm in Book 3 attributed to David. It is a personal prayer in the middle of a series of national psalms of Asaph and the sons of Korah. The psalmist is surrounded by insolent men, but the focus is on God's character. It takes up the language of Exodus 34:6, which you saw in Jonah: "merciful and gracious, slow to anger." The psalm balances Isaiah's mighty God with the personal God who hears one man.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Incline your ear, O LORD, and answer me, for I am poor and needy" (v. 1).
2. "Preserve my life, for I am godly; save your servant, who trusts in you" (v. 2).
3. "Gladden the soul of your servant, for to you, O Lord, do I lift up my soul" (v. 4).
4. "For you, O Lord, are good and forgiving, abounding in steadfast love to all who call on you" (v. 5).
5. "There is none like you among the gods, O Lord, nor are there any works like yours" (v. 8).
6. "All the nations you have made shall come and worship before you, O Lord" (v. 9).
7. "Teach me your way, O LORD, that I may walk in your truth; unite my heart to fear your name" (v. 11).

8 “But you, O Lord, are a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness” (v. 15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts with the simplest sort of prayer: “I am poor and needy.” David does not mean he lacks money. He means he has nothing that gives him a claim on God. Every request that follows rests on God’s character. “Preserve my life, for I am godly” does not boast of perfection but states his covenant loyalty. “You are good and forgiving, abounding in steadfast love to all who call on you.” That is the heart of the psalm. He asks because God is generous.

David repeatedly calls himself “your servant,” three times in the psalm. The word shows his posture: he belongs to God and depends on him. Being a servant means that he can ask for the master’s protection. And his daily prayer is persistent. “I cry to you all the day.”

Verses 8 to 10 widen the view: no one is like the LORD. All nations will come and worship. This echoes Isaiah 45:22-23 and the mission to the nations. Even a personal prayer is set in a universal frame.

The central request is in verse 11: “Teach me your way, O LORD, that I may walk in your truth; unite my heart to fear your name.” David asks for a divided heart to be united. Anyone who has tried to follow God knows how scattered the heart can be, pulled in many directions. He prays that God would gather it into a single loyalty. It is a prayer that is worth praying every day.

Then he thanks God for deliverance from Sheol. The proud have risen against him. He asks for a sign of God’s goodness, “that those who hate me may see and be put to shame, because you, LORD, have helped me and comforted me.” The psalm moves from need to confidence, and its core is God’s self-description from Exodus 34, spoken back to him in prayer.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Psalm 86 in the thought that all nations will worship (Romans 15:9-11, along with Psalm 18 and others). Revelation 15:4 says, “All nations will come and worship you.” Ephesians 2:4-5 speaks of God, rich in mercy. James 4:8 says, “Draw near to God, and he will draw near to you… purify your hearts, you double-minded.” Matthew 6:22 and Psalm 119:113 address wholeheartedness. 2 Corinthians 1:3-4 calls him the Father of mercies and God of all comfort.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Psalm 86:11 each morning this week: “Unite my heart to fear your name.”

Begin a prayer by admitting that you are “poor and needy,” with nothing to bring but your need.

Speak God’s own words about himself (Exodus 34:6) back to him in a prayer of trust.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God that you are poor and needy.

Thank him that he is good and forgiving.

Ask him to teach you his way.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 58

“But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint.”

ISAIAH 40:31

DAY 405 · WEEK 58

Psalm 89:1-37

I will sing of the steadfast love of the LORD

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 37 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 89:1-37. The first half of the psalm celebrates God's covenant with David. It is a magnificent statement of confidence. Keep in mind that the second half of the psalm (verses 38-52), which comes later in the plan, brings a painful question.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 89 is a Maskil of Ethan the Ezrahite and the last psalm of Book 3. It was probably written after the Babylonian exile began, when the Davidic king had been taken captive. Yet the first thirty-seven verses are full of praise for the covenant God made with David in 2 Samuel 7. It is placed here in Unit 12 as a bridge between Isaiah's promises of a coming king and the later crisis. Verses 38 to 52 appear in Unit 13.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will sing of the steadfast love of the LORD, forever; with my mouth I will make known your faithfulness to all generations" (v. 1).
2. "For I said, Steadfast love will be built up forever; in the heavens you will establish your faithfulness" (v. 2).
3. "You have said, I have made a covenant with my chosen one; I have sworn to David my servant" (v. 3).
4. "Who in the skies can be compared to the LORD? Who among the heavenly beings is like the LORD?" (v. 6).
5. "Blessed are the people who know the festal shout, who walk, O LORD, in the light of your face" (v. 15).

6. “I have found David, my servant; with my holy oil I have anointed him” (v. 20).
7. “He shall cry to me, You are my Father, my God, and the Rock of my salvation” (v. 26).
8. “I will not violate my covenant or alter the word that went forth from my lips” (v. 34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with the word “steadfast love” and “faithfulness,” repeated throughout. These two words are used seven times in the first part of the psalm. The psalmist makes a vow: he will sing of them forever. His confidence rests on what God has said and sworn. God’s love is not a feeling that fluctuates but a covenant that stands.

The first section praises God as the creator and ruler. The heavens praise his wonders. No one is like him. He rules the raging sea, stills its waves, and crushed Rahab, the sea monster. North and south, Tabor and Hermon, all belong to him. And such a God is not distant. Blessed are those who walk in the light of his face.

The second part, verses 19 to 37, recalls the covenant with David in detail. God chose David from among the people, anointed him, strengthened him. He promised that David would call him Father, and that God would make him the firstborn, “the highest of the kings of the earth.” His line would endure as long as the heavens. Even if his sons sin, God says, “I will punish their transgression with the rod,” but “I will not remove from him my steadfast love.” Then the oath: “Once for all I have sworn by my holiness; I will not lie to David.”

Why does this matter in Unit 12? Because Isaiah’s promises of a child, a shoot of Jesse, and a servant all depend on the covenant with David. The psalm is the legal basis for hope. When Judah’s kingdom is threatened, this is what the faithful return to: God has sworn, and he will not lie.

The psalm’s second half asks, “But now you have cast off and rejected.” The painful tension between promise and experience is what the Old Testament waits for Christ to resolve.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 1:32-33 says that the angel told Mary her son would be given the throne of his father David. Acts 13:22-23 says God raised up from David’s offspring a Savior, Jesus. Hebrews 1:5 uses 2 Samuel 7 to say “I will be to him a father.” Colossians 1:18 calls Jesus “the firstborn of all creation” and “the firstborn from the dead.” Revelation 1:5 calls him “the ruler of kings on earth.” Romans 15:8 says Christ confirmed the promises given to the patriarchs.

STEP 6

Application

Choose to sing, or read aloud, Psalm 89:1 as a vow to make known God's faithfulness.

Think about one promise of God that you are holding on to. Write down the verse and what it says.

Thank God that his covenant is not broken by our failure, because Christ has fulfilled it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Sing of God's steadfast love in your own words.

Thank him for his sworn promise to David.

Ask him to make known his faithfulness to those who come after you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 58

"But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint."

ISAIAH 40:31

DAY 406 · WEEK 58

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Isaiah 40:31 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint."

ISAIAH 40:31

REST

Meditation

This verse comes at the end of a long argument. The exiles in Babylon had said, "My way is hidden from the LORD." Isaiah answers with a series of reasons to hope: the LORD is the Creator, never weary, whose understanding no one can fathom. And then comes the promise.

"But they who wait for the LORD." The Hebrew word for wait does not mean to sit idly. It means to hope, to look expectantly, as a person watches for the dawn. It has the sense of being bound to someone, twisted together like a rope. To wait for the LORD is to tie your hope to him. This is not passive. It is a posture of active trust.

"Shall renew their strength." The word "renew" means exchange. We trade our strength for his. The previous verses say that even the young grow faint and weary, and young men fall exhausted. Human strength has limits. But those who wait on God exchange their exhaustion

for his inexhaustible power.

Then three pictures, in an unusual order. “They shall mount up with wings like eagles.” This is the most dramatic. “They shall run and not be weary.” This is steadier. “They shall walk and not faint.” This is the most ordinary, and perhaps the greatest miracle. Most of life is walking, not soaring. The promise is that God will sustain us in the daily grind as well as in the heights.

Say this verse in a time of fatigue. You may not feel like an eagle today. You may only be walking. The promise is that you will not faint, for you are leaning on the one who “does not faint or grow weary” (Isaiah 40:28).

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you stood with Judah as Jerusalem celebrated its deliverance from Assyria, singing Psalms 46 and 48, with their refrain, “The LORD of hosts is with us,” and their command, “Be still, and know that I am God.” Then you crossed the great divide in the book of Isaiah. In chapters 40 to 42, God speaks comfort to exiles, prepares a highway in the wilderness, and introduces the Servant who will not break a bruised reed. In chapters 43 to 45, you heard the LORD claim his people by name, declare that there is no savior besides him, and name Cyrus as his shepherd. You prayed Psalm 86, a prayer of the poor and needy to a God who is good and forgiving, and Psalm 89, a song about the covenant God swore to David. The week taught that God comforts his people, that he is the only God, and that his covenant promises stand.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Isaiah 40 begins, “Comfort, comfort my people.” Where do you most need to hear God’s comfort right now?

The Servant of Isaiah 42 does not break a bruised reed. How does Jesus’ gentleness with the weak change how you approach him in your own weakness?

God says, “I have called you by name, you are mine.” What difference would it make today if you lived as someone who truly belongs to him?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to give power to the faint, and tell him where you are faint.

Thank him for the Servant who does not break a bruised reed.

Wait for him and ask him to renew your strength.

DAY 407 · WEEK 59

Isaiah 46:1-49:26

Babylon's gods fail; "I have called you by name"

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 100 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 46:1-49:26. Babylon's gods are carried off on wagons, Babylon herself falls, and the Servant speaks in the first person. Notice the contrast between a god who must be carried and a God who carries.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The prophet speaks to exiles who see the glittering idols of Babylon every day. Chapters 46 and 47 contrast the gods who are carried with the God who carries, and announce the fall of proud Babylon. In chapters 48 and 49, God exhorts a stubborn people, and the second Servant Song appears. Here the Servant speaks for himself, and we learn that his work is larger than Israel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Bel bows down; Nebo stoops; their idols are on beasts and livestock; these things you carry are loaded as burdens on weary beasts" (46:1).
2. "Even to your old age I am he, and to gray hairs I will carry you. I have made, and I will bear; I will carry and will save" (46:4).
3. "I am God, and there is none like me, declaring the end from the beginning" (46:9-10).
4. "You said, I shall be mistress forever" (47:7).
5. "I am the LORD your God, who teaches you to profit, who leads you in the way you should go" (48:17).
6. "The LORD called me from the womb, from the body of my mother he named my name" (49:1).

7. “It is too light a thing that you should be my servant to raise up the tribes of Jacob… I will make you as a light for the nations, that my salvation may reach to the end of the earth” (49:6).

8. “Can a woman forget her nursing child… Even these may forget, yet I will not forget you. Behold, I have engraved you on the palms of my hands” (49:15-16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 46 gives a stark image. The great gods of Babylon, Bel and Nebo, are loaded onto animals and carted off into captivity. Idols are heavy burdens that have to be carried, and they cannot save. Over against them is the God who carries: “I have made, and I will bear; I will carry and will save.” The difference between the true God and the false is the difference between a weight and a carrier. One needs to be carried by us. The other carries us, from birth to gray hairs.

Chapter 47 is a taunt song against Babylon, depicted as a pampered queen who sits on a throne and is told to sit in the dust. She thought, “I am, and there is no one besides me,” a boast that belongs only to God. Her sorcerers and astrologers cannot save her. The pride that exalts itself to the place of God is brought low.

In chapter 48, God addresses the stubborn exiles who invoke his name but not in truth. He declares the future before it happens so that they cannot say their idols did it. And he laments: “Oh that you had paid attention to my commandments! Then your peace would have been like a river.” Yet he will bring them out: “Go out from Babylon, flee from Chaldea.”

Chapter 49 introduces the Servant speaking, “Listen to me, O coastlands.” He was called before birth, his mouth made like a sharp sword, hidden in the shadow of God’s hand. Strikingly, he says, “I have labored in vain.” Yet his work is given to God. The commission is expanded: it is too light a thing to restore Israel alone. He will be “a light for the nations.” The Servant’s mission is global.

The chapter ends with the loveliest assurance. Zion says, “The LORD has forsaken me.” God answers that a mother may forget her nursing child, but he will not forget. “I have engraved you on the palms of my hands.” The hands that were scarred are the hands that remember.

STEP 5

Connection

Simeon quoted Isaiah 49:6 when he held the infant Jesus and called him “a light for revelation to the Gentiles” (Luke 2:32). Paul and Barnabas applied it to their mission in Acts 13:47. In John 8:12, Jesus says, “I am the light of the world.” The scars on the hands of Jesus

(John 20:27) are the true fulfillment of “engraved on the palms of my hands.” Revelation 18 shows the fall of Babylon the great.

STEP 6

Application

Name something you are carrying that you were never meant to carry, and give it to the God who carries.

Read Isaiah 49:15-16 slowly, and let it reassure you if you feel forgotten.

Pray for the spread of the gospel to the ends of the earth, as the Servant’s mission calls.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he will carry you to your old age.

Thank him that you are engraved on the palms of his hands.

Tell him what idol you are tempted to carry yourself.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 59

“But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed.”

ISAIAH 53:5

DAY 408 · WEEK 59

Isaiah 50:1-53:12

The Servant's obedience; the suffering servant

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 74 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 50:1-53:12. This is the heart of the book. The Servant is obedient, beaten, and then, in chapter 53, pierced for our transgressions. Read Isaiah 52:13-53:12 twice. Let the language slow you down.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters contain the third and fourth Servant Songs. Isaiah 50:4-9 describes the Servant's willing suffering. Isaiah 52:13 to 53:12 is the most famous passage in the Old Testament about the Messiah's suffering and death. It was written about 700 years before Jesus. Early Christians, including Philip with the Ethiopian official in Acts 8, took this chapter as the key to understanding the gospel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I gave my back to those who strike, and my cheeks to those who pull out the beard; I hid not my face from disgrace and spitting" (50:6).
2. "But the Lord GOD helps me; therefore I have not been disgraced" (50:7).
3. "Awake, awake, put on your strength, O arm of the LORD" (51:9).
4. "How beautiful upon the mountains are the feet of him who brings good news, who publishes peace" (52:7).
5. "Behold, my servant shall act wisely; he shall be high and lifted up, and shall be exalted" (52:13).
6. "He was despised and rejected by men, a man of sorrows and acquainted with grief" (53:3).

7. “Surely he has borne our griefs and carried our sorrows; yet we esteemed him stricken, smitten by God, and afflicted” (53:4).

8. “But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed” (53:5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 50 gives the Servant’s own voice. He is a disciple who listens, with an ear opened by God, morning by morning. He does not turn back. He gives his back to those who strike, and his face to those who spit. Yet he has set his face like a flint. His trust is in the God who helps him, and so he is not put to shame. The perfect obedience the Servant gives is what Israel never offered.

Chapter 51 and the beginning of 52 contain a great call to awake. God’s arm is stirred as in the days of old, when he cut Rahab in pieces and dried up the sea. And the ransomed of the LORD will return with singing. “How beautiful upon the mountains are the feet of him who brings good news.” The whole earth will see the salvation of our God.

Then comes the fourth song. It begins with a surprise. The Servant will be “high and lifted up,” language used of God in Isaiah 6. Yet his appearance was marred beyond human semblance. Kings will shut their mouths because of him. Then the confession of the people begins in 53:1. He grew up like a tender plant, with no form or majesty. He was despised, rejected, a man of sorrows. “We esteemed him stricken, smitten by God.” We thought he was being punished for his own sins. But verses 5 and 6 reveal the truth: “He was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities.” Everything he suffered was for us. “All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned every one to his own way; and the LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all.”

The Servant is silent like a lamb led to the slaughter. He was cut off from the land of the living, assigned a grave with the wicked and with a rich man in his death, though he had done no violence. Yet “it was the will of the LORD to crush him.” Out of his anguish he will see light and be satisfied. “By his knowledge shall the righteous one, my servant, make many to be accounted righteous, and he shall bear their iniquities.” He pours out his soul to death, is numbered with the transgressors, bears the sin of many, and makes intercession.

STEP 5

Connection

Philip began with Isaiah 53 and told the Ethiopian official the good news about Jesus (Acts 8:32-35). 1 Peter 2:22-25 draws on this chapter for the cross. Matthew 8:17 sees Jesus’ healing as fulfilling “he took our illnesses.” Mark 10:45 says the Son of Man came “to give his life as a

ransom for many." Luke 22:37 quotes "he was numbered with the transgressors." Romans 5:19 speaks of the many being made righteous through one man's obedience.

STEP 6

Application

Read Isaiah 53:4-6 aloud and replace "our" with "my." Let it become personal.

Thank Jesus specifically for one thing he bore for you: your guilt, shame, sorrow, or sickness.

Share the good news of this chapter with someone this week, as Philip did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being despised and rejected for you.
- Tell him what it means that he was pierced for your transgressions.
- Ask him to make you trust his healing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 59

"But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed."

ISAIAH 53:5

DAY 409 · WEEK 59

Isaiah 53:1-12; Romans 3:21-26; Hebrews 9:11-28

The Work of Christ, Atonement

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 53:1-12, then Romans 3:21-26, and then Hebrews 9:11-28. Today is a doctrinal pause, so you are reading three passages together: the prophet's picture of the suffering Servant, Paul's explanation of how God justifies sinners, and the author of Hebrews on the blood of Christ. Ask as you read: what exactly did Jesus accomplish on the cross, and how?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

You read Isaiah 53 yesterday. Today you read it again, alongside two New Testament passages that interpret it. Paul explains that God's righteousness is shown in the cross and that sinners are justified by grace through faith. The author of Hebrews shows that Christ's sacrifice fulfills and surpasses the Old Testament sacrifices. Together they give us the doctrine of the atonement, the work of Christ in dealing with sin.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities" (Isaiah 53:5).
2. "The LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all" (Isaiah 53:6).
3. "For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus" (Romans 3:23-24).
4. "Whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith" (Romans 3:25).

5. “This was to show God’s righteousness, because in his divine forbearance he had passed over former sins” (Romans 3:25).
6. “That he might be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus” (Romans 3:26).
7. “He entered once for all into the holy places, not by means of the blood of goats and calves but by means of his own blood, thus securing an eternal redemption” (Hebrews 9:12).
8. “Without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness of sins” (Hebrews 9:22).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The atonement is the work of Christ on the cross by which sinners are reconciled to God. The word itself means “at-one-ment,” the making of peace between two parties who were estranged. The Bible uses several pictures to describe what happened, and each adds something.

The first is sacrifice. In the Old Testament, an animal died in the place of the sinner, and its blood covered the guilt. Hebrews says that these sacrifices were a shadow. They could not take away sins, which is why they had to be repeated. Christ offered himself once for all, a perfect sacrifice. The second is substitution. Isaiah 53 says the Servant bore our iniquities and was pierced for our transgressions. He took our place. The penalty we deserved fell on him. This is sometimes called penal substitution: he bore the penalty in our place.

The third is propitiation. Romans 3:25 says God put forward Christ as a propitiation, a sacrifice that satisfies God’s righteous wrath against sin. This is not a picture of an angry God being calmed by a loving Son. It is God himself who puts forward the sacrifice, out of love. The Father, Son, and Spirit were united in this work. The fourth is redemption. A ransom price was paid to buy slaves out of bondage. Christ’s blood is the price (Mark 10:45; 1 Peter 1:18-19). The fifth is victory. Colossians 2:15 says that on the cross Christ triumphed over the rulers and authorities.

Romans 3:26 states the great puzzle that the cross solves: how can God be both just and the justifier of the ungodly? He cannot simply ignore sin, for he is righteous. The cross shows that he does not ignore it. The penalty is paid. And so God can freely forgive those who trust in Christ.

For believers, the atonement is the ground of our assurance. Our standing before God does not depend on our performance. It depends on what Christ has finished.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three passages work like three voices in harmony. Isaiah gives the story in prophetic language. A righteous Servant suffers for others, though he did nothing wrong. The language is of sin-bearing and healing. “The LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all.” Notice that the Father is the one who lays it on him. This was not an accident or a tragedy. “It was the will of the LORD to crush him.” It was God’s plan, carried out in love.

Paul explains why this had to happen. All have sinned, and there is no distinction. No one can earn a place before God. But God offers justification as a gift. To justify means to declare righteous, a legal term. We are not made righteous by our deeds. God declares us righteous because of what Christ has done. This is received by faith, not earned. Paul also says that God “passed over former sins” in his forbearance, meaning that before the cross he had been patient with sin. The cross shows that this patience was not indifference. The debt was real, and it was finally paid.

Hebrews approaches it through the temple. The old high priest entered the Holy of Holies once a year with the blood of animals. Christ, by contrast, entered heaven itself with his own blood, once for all, “securing an eternal redemption.” The old covenant’s sacrifices only cleansed the flesh. Christ’s blood “purifies our conscience from dead works to serve the living God.” And he is the mediator of a new covenant, so that those who are called may receive the promised eternal inheritance. Because he is both priest and sacrifice, nothing more needs to be offered.

Put together, these texts show that the cross was necessary, because sin is serious and God is just. It was sufficient, because Christ’s offering was perfect. And it was personal. The Servant bore “our” sins, and Christ gave himself “for me” (Galatians 2:20).

STEP 5

Connection

Mark 10:45 says Christ came to give his life as a ransom for many. 2 Corinthians 5:21 says, “For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God.” Galatians 3:13 says Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us. 1 John 2:2 and 4:10 speak of him as the propitiation for our sins. Ephesians 1:7 says that in him we have redemption through his blood. Hebrews 10:14 says that by a single offering he has perfected for all time those who are being sanctified.

STEP 6

Application

Write down, in your own words, what Christ did on the cross for you. Use at least two of the pictures: sacrifice, substitution, ransom, victory.

Rest in the finished work. Ask where you are still trying to earn what has been given.

Share one of these truths with someone who is weighed down by guilt.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank the Father for laying on his Son the iniquity of all.

Thank Jesus for bearing your sins.

Tell God how you want to live in light of the cross.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 59

"But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed."

ISAIAH 53:5

DAY 410 · WEEK 59

Isaiah 54:1-57:21

Covenant expanded; "come, everyone who thirsts"

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 54:1-57:21. After the cross of chapter 53 comes the fruit: a barren woman sings, the covenant is widened, and everyone who thirsts is invited to come. Read Isaiah 55 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 54 follows directly from the Servant's death. Because the Servant gave himself, Zion, a woman barren and desolate, will have many children. The following chapters broaden the invitation. The gate is opened to foreigners and eunuchs who were once excluded. The covenant now rests on grace. And the section ends with a warning that there is no peace for the wicked.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Sing, O barren one, who did not bear; break forth into singing and cry aloud" (54:1).
2. "For a brief moment I deserted you, but with great compassion I will gather you" (54:7).
3. "For the mountains may depart and the hills be removed, but my steadfast love shall not depart from you" (54:10).
4. "No weapon that is fashioned against you shall succeed" (54:17).
5. "Come, everyone who thirsts, come to the waters; and he who has no money, come, buy and eat!" (55:1).
6. "Seek the LORD while he may be found; call upon him while he is near" (55:6).
7. "For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways, declares the LORD" (55:8).

8 “So shall my word be that goes out from my mouth; it shall not return to me empty” (55:11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The command to sing in chapter 54 is startling. The one addressed is a barren woman, and yet she is told to sing, for the children of the desolate will be more than those of the married. The cross has made this possible. Because the Servant was cut off from the land of the living, many are born. The promises that follow are tender. God is her husband, her redeemer. He admits that for a moment he forsook her in his anger, but with everlasting love he has compassion. And he swears, as in the days of Noah, that he will not be angry with her again. The mountains may depart, but his love will not.

Chapter 55 is one of the greatest invitations in the Bible. “Come, everyone who thirsts.” It is free: “He who has no money, come, buy and eat… without money and without price.” The paradox of buying without money states the nature of grace. The question: “Why do you spend your money for that which is not bread, and your labor for that which does not satisfy?” It describes the empty pursuits of the world. God offers an everlasting covenant, the “sure mercies of David,” now extended to all.

The call is urgent: “Seek the LORD while he may be found.” It includes a call to repentance: “Let the wicked forsake his way… let him return to the LORD, that he may have compassion on him, and to our God, for he will abundantly pardon.” The reason for confidence is that God’s ways are higher than ours: “As the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways.” This is not a statement of distance but of generosity. His pardon is greater than we think possible. And his word is effective, like rain that waters the earth. It does not return empty.

Chapter 56 is a surprising word of inclusion. Foreigners and eunuchs, who were barred from the assembly in the law, are welcomed. “My house shall be called a house of prayer for all peoples.” Chapter 57 then contrasts the contrite and humble, with whom God dwells, to the wicked, who have no peace.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink” (John 7:37) and to the woman at the well offered living water (John 4:10-14). Revelation 22:17 invites, “Let the one who is thirsty come; let the one who desires take the water of life without price.” Jesus quoted Isaiah

56:7 when he cleansed the temple (Mark 11:17). Galatians 4:27 quotes Isaiah 54:1. Acts 13:34 quotes “the sure mercies of David” as fulfilled in Christ’s resurrection. Matthew 5:3 echoes “the poor in spirit” of Isaiah 57:15.

STEP 6

Application

Accept Isaiah 55:1 as an invitation. What are you spending on “that which is not bread”? Bring that thirst to God.

Welcome someone who has been left out of your circle, as God welcomed the foreigner and the eunuch.

Trust the word you read, as rain that waters the earth and will not return empty.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you are thirsty for.
- Confess where you have spent your labor on what does not satisfy.
- Ask him to help you seek him while he may be found.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 59

“But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed.”

ISAIAH 53:5

DAY 411 · WEEK 59

Psalm 22

From the horns of the wild oxen you have rescued me

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 22. You have read parts of this psalm twice before in earlier units. Read it again now with Isaiah 53 open beside it. Both describe a righteous sufferer who is forsaken, pierced, and then vindicated, so that the nations turn to the LORD.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 22 is a psalm of David, and the Gospels show Jesus praying its first line from the cross. Paired with the fourth Servant Song, it shows the suffering and glory that the Old Testament predicts for the Messiah. Notice especially the second half, in which the sufferer is delivered and the result is worldwide worship. That is the same pattern as Isaiah 53:10-12.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? Why are you so far from saving me?” (v. 1).
2. “But I am a worm and not a man, scorned by mankind and despised by the people” (v. 6).
3. “All who see me mock me; they make mouths at me; they wag their heads” (v. 7).
4. “They have pierced my hands and feet” (v. 16).
5. “They divide my garments among them, and for my clothing they cast lots” (v. 18).
6. “You who fear the LORD, praise him! … For he has not despised or abhorred the affliction of the afflicted” (vv. 23-24).
7. “All the ends of the earth shall remember and turn to the LORD, and all the families of the nations shall worship before you” (v. 27).

8 “They shall come and proclaim his righteousness to a people yet unborn, that he has done it” (v. 31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Read beside Isaiah 53, the psalm reveals the same shape. The Servant is despised and rejected, and the psalmist is “a worm and not a man, scorned by mankind.” The Servant is silent before his accusers, and the psalmist is surrounded by bulls, lions, and dogs. The Servant is pierced and crushed, and the psalmist’s bones are out of joint, his heart like wax, his strength dried up. Even his clothes are divided. And then in both, the turn.

In Isaiah 53:10-11, “he shall see his offspring; he shall prolong his days… out of the anguish of his soul he shall see and be satisfied.” In Psalm 22:21-22, the sufferer is heard and begins to declare God’s name to his brothers and praise him in the congregation. The suffering was not the end.

Verses 24 to 31 are the surprising conclusion. God “has not despised or abhorred the affliction of the afflicted, and he has not hidden his face from him, but has heard, when he cried to him.” The cry of dereliction is answered. And its effect is global: “All the ends of the earth shall remember and turn to the LORD.” The affliction of one man brings all nations to worship. “The poor shall eat and be satisfied.” Compare Isaiah 53:11, “make many to be accounted righteous,” and Isaiah 49:6, a light for the nations.

The psalm ends with the future generations: “They shall come and proclaim his righteousness to a people yet unborn, that he has done it.” The Hebrew for “that he has done it” is a single word, much like Jesus’ cry, “It is finished.”

Why is it here? Because Isaiah’s Servant is not an abstract idea. Real suffering is involved, in real flesh. The psalm gives the Servant a voice. It shows what he felt: abandonment, mockery, thirst, and yet, trust, and ultimately praise. Because of this, Christians in suffering have a companion in the one who prayed this psalm to the end.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus cried, “Eli, Eli, lema sabachthani” on the cross (Matthew 27:46), and the details of Psalm 22 are found throughout the passion narratives: mocking (Matthew 27:39-43), the dividing of garments (John 19:23-24), thirst (John 19:28). Hebrews 2:12 puts verse 22 on Jesus’ lips. Revelation 7:9 shows people from all nations worshiping. John 19:30 records “It is finished.” Romans 8:34 says Christ is at the right hand of God, interceding.

STEP 6

Application

Read the psalm aloud as Jesus' prayer. Thank him for walking through abandonment so that you never have to be abandoned.

If you feel forsaken, pray verse 1 honestly, and then continue reading to verse 24.

Pray for a nation or people group that has not heard the gospel, using verse 27.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he did not despise the affliction of his Son.

Thank Jesus for crying out in forsakenness for you.

Ask him to make you tell others of what he has done.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 59

"But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed."

ISAIAH 53:5

DAY 412 · WEEK 59

Psalm 69:1-21

Save me, O God; reproach has broken my heart

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 69:1-21. It is a cry of deep suffering from one who is hated for the sake of God. Notice how often the New Testament quotes this psalm.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 69 is a psalm of David. It is one of the most quoted psalms in the New Testament, second only to Psalm 22. The psalmist is sinking in deep waters, exhausted from crying, and hated without cause. What makes his suffering unusual is that it comes because of his zeal for God. It pairs well with Isaiah's Servant, who suffered on behalf of others. It will appear again in Unit 18 with a different focus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Save me, O God! For the waters have come up to my neck" (v. 1).
2. "I sink in deep mire, where there is no foothold" (v. 2).
3. "More in number than the hairs of my head are those who hate me without cause" (v. 4).
4. "What I did not steal must I now restore?" (v. 4).
5. "For it is for your sake that I have borne reproach, that dishonor has covered my face" (v. 7).
6. "I have become a stranger to my brothers, an alien to my mother's sons" (v. 8).
7. "For zeal for your house has consumed me, and the reproaches of those who reproach you have fallen on me" (v. 9).
8. "They gave me poison for food, and for my thirst they gave me sour wine to drink" (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening images are those of drowning: deep waters, mire, floods. The psalmist is worn out with calling for help, his throat parched, his eyes failing from waiting for God. The suffering is intense, and it appears to come from several sources: false accusations, the loss of family, the mockery of those at the gate and the drunkards' songs.

The unusual feature is the reason for it. "For it is for your sake that I have borne reproach." His loyalty to God has made him a target. His zeal for God's house has consumed him, and the insults aimed at God have landed on him. He has fasted and wept, and been mocked for it. There is no sense that the suffering is deserved. Though he acknowledges that he is not without folly (v. 5), the accusation against him is false.

The prayer turns on God's steadfast love. "But as for me, my prayer is to you, O LORD. At an acceptable time, O God, in the abundance of your steadfast love answer me." He asks God to rescue him from the mire, and he appeals to God's goodness: "Answer me, O LORD, for your steadfast love is good; according to your abundant mercy, turn to me." Then comes the heartbreaking description of verses 20 and 21: "Reproaches have broken my heart, so that I am in despair. I looked for pity, but there was none, and for comforters, but I found none. They gave me poison for food, and for my thirst they gave me sour wine to drink."

This psalm helps us see the Servant's suffering from the inside. The Servant is despised and rejected, with no one to comfort him. Yet the psalm leaves us with a question: what should the sufferer do? His answer is to pray. He does not repay hatred with hatred but brings his anguish to God. For the believer who suffers for righteousness' sake, the psalm is a guide and a comfort.

STEP 5

Connection

John 2:17 quotes verse 9, "Zeal for your house will consume me," when Jesus cleansed the temple. John 15:25 quotes verse 4, "They hated me without a cause." Romans 15:3 quotes verse 9, "The reproaches of those who reproached you fell on me," about Christ. Matthew 27:34, 48 and John 19:28-29 record the sour wine on the cross. Acts 1:20 quotes verse 25 in connection with Judas. 1 Peter 4:14 says that if we are insulted for the name of Christ, we are blessed.

STEP 6

Application

If you are suffering for doing right, bring it to God in honest prayer, and do not repay evil for evil.

Ask for the same zeal for God's house that Jesus had, a love for the church that is real and costly.

Look for someone who has "looked for pity and found none." Be the comforter.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry out to God about what overwhelms you.
- Thank Jesus for the zeal that consumed him.
- Ask him to teach you to bear reproach for his sake.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 59

"But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed."

ISAIAH 53:5

DAY 413 · WEEK 59

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Isaiah 53:5 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed."

ISAIAH 53:5

REST

Meditation

This is the heart of the Old Testament's picture of the cross. It was written some seven centuries before Jesus was born, and it describes what he would do in language that is hard to read without wonder.

"But he was pierced for our transgressions." The word "pierced" means run through, wounded to the point of death. The Servant's wounds are connected to something: our transgressions. The sin was ours. The piercing was his. "He was crushed for our iniquities." The word "crushed" is the strongest word for breaking something to pieces. Iniquity is twisted behavior. Each phrase is a transfer. What belonged to us was borne by him.

"Upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace." Chastisement is discipline, the punishment that was due. It fell on him, and the result is peace for us. Think about what this peace is: not just a feeling of calm, but reconciliation with God. The war between a holy God

and a rebellious people has ended.

“And with his wounds we are healed.” The healing is the forgiveness of sins and the restoration of the whole person. 1 Peter 2:24 says that “by his wounds you have been healed.” The wounds that made him unrecognizable are the means of our wholeness. The scars of Christ are the glory of the gospel.

This verse can be said at any time. When you feel guilt, say it. When you are tempted to believe that you must earn God’s favor, say it. When you meet someone who has no hope, tell them. The Servant was wounded for us, and the debt is paid.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you walked through the center of Isaiah. You saw the idols of Babylon carried off on animals, while the true God carries his people from birth to old age. You heard the Servant speak, call him to be a light for the nations, and learned that God has engraved his people on the palms of his hands. Then you came to the heart of the book: the Servant who gave his back to those who strike, who was despised and rejected, pierced for our transgressions, and crushed for our iniquities. On Wednesday’s doctrinal pause you traced the doctrine of the atonement through sacrifice, substitution, propitiation, redemption, and victory. After the cross came the invitation of Isaiah 55, “Come, everyone who thirsts.” And you prayed Psalms 22 and 69, in which the suffering Messiah speaks for himself. The week taught that Jesus bore our sins, that God is both just and the justifier, and that the invitation is free.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Isaiah 53 says the Servant was pierced for our transgressions. What does it mean to you personally that Jesus took your place?

The doctrinal pause described the atonement through several pictures. Which one speaks most clearly to your own need right now: sacrifice, substitution, ransom, or victory?

Isaiah 55 invites everyone who thirsts to come without money. What would it mean for you to accept this invitation without trying to earn it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that he was pierced and crushed for you.

Thank him that by his wounds you are healed.

Rest in the peace he bought.

DAY 414 · WEEK 60

Isaiah 58:1-60:22

True fasting; the Spirit's anointing; Zion's future glory

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 58:1-60:22. God describes the fast he wants, the Servant speaks about the Spirit's anointing, and the future glory of Zion shines like sunrise. Read chapter 58 as a challenge, and chapter 60 as a promise.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The last section of Isaiah, chapters 56 to 66, addresses a community that has begun to return from exile, or is on the verge of it, and finds the promised glory slow to appear. The people ask why God does not notice their fasting. The answer is that religion without justice is empty. Then the section moves on to the Spirit-anointed one, a new covenant, and a future in which the nations stream to the light of Zion.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Cry aloud; do not hold back; lift up your voice like a trumpet; declare to my people their transgression" (58:1).
2. "Is not this the fast that I choose: to loose the bonds of wickedness, to undo the straps of the yoke, to let the oppressed go free?" (58:6).
3. "Is it not to share your bread with the hungry and bring the homeless poor into your house?" (58:7).
4. "Then shall your light break forth like the dawn, and your healing shall spring up speedily" (58:8).
5. "Behold, the LORD's hand is not shortened, that it cannot save... but your iniquities have made a separation between you and your God" (59:1-2).

6. “He saw that there was no man, and wondered that there was no one to intercede; then his own arm brought him salvation” (59:16).
7. “And a Redeemer will come to Zion, to those in Jacob who turn from transgression” (59:20).
8. “Arise, shine, for your light has come, and the glory of the LORD has risen upon you” (60:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 58 begins with a surprise. The people seem religious, “seeking” God daily, delighting to know his ways. They fast, and they wonder why God does not see. God answers that on the day of their fast they pursue their own interests and oppress their workers. They fast with quarreling and strife. A day of bowing the head like a reed is not what God wants. The fast that he chooses is to set the oppressed free, share bread with the hungry, shelter the homeless, and clothe the naked. This is Isaiah 1 again. True worship cannot be separated from compassion.

The promise attached to this obedience is wonderful. “Then shall your light break forth like the dawn.” “You shall be like a watered garden.” And the Sabbath is also mentioned: delight in it, and God will cause you to ride on the heights of the earth.

Chapter 59 turns to the problem beneath. The LORD’s hand is not too short to save. It is sin that separates. The chapter is a bleak confession of corporate guilt: “Our transgressions are multiplied before you.” Justice is turned back, truth stumbles in the street. “He saw that there was no man… then his own arm brought him salvation.” God himself, a divine warrior, puts on righteousness as a breastplate and the helmet of salvation. “And a Redeemer will come to Zion.” A new covenant is promised: “My Spirit that is upon you, and my words that I have put in your mouth, shall not depart.”

Chapter 60 is a wave of light. Darkness covers the earth, but the LORD rises over Zion, and nations come to her light. Kings come to the brightness of her rising. Her gates are open continually. The sun and moon are replaced by the LORD as an everlasting light. “Your people shall all be righteous; they shall possess the land forever.” The people who were exiles become a glorious city.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Whatever you did for one of the least of these, you did for me” (Matthew 25:35-40). James 1:27 and 2:14-17 echo the call to practical compassion. Paul uses the armor of Isaiah 59:17 in Ephesians 6:14-17. Romans 11:26-27 quotes Isaiah 59:20-21 about the

Redeemer. Jesus said, “I am the light of the world” (John 8:12), and Revelation 21:23-25 shows the city lit by the glory of God, its gates never shut, and the nations walking by its light.

STEP 6

Application

Choose one concrete act of justice or mercy: share a meal, give to the poor, or help someone out of a hard situation.

Ask how your spiritual practices, such as fasting, prayer, and church, affect how you treat people.

Let the light of Christ shine in a dark place this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to teach you the fast he chooses, and ask how you can share bread with the hungry.

Confess where your religion has been empty.

Ask him to let your light rise.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 60

“Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!”

ISAIAH 6:3

DAY 415 · WEEK 60

Isaiah 61:1-63:14

The year of the LORD's favor; the divine warrior

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 61:1-63:14. In chapter 61 an anointed one announces good news, which Jesus read aloud in the synagogue at Nazareth. Then comes a vision of a divine warrior and a long memory of the exodus. Read 61:1-3 as if you were in that synagogue.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaiah 61 is a text that Jesus chose to read at the beginning of his public ministry (Luke 4:16-21). It describes an anointed herald who announces release to captives. Chapter 62 speaks of Zion's new name and of God's delight in her as a bridegroom delights in his bride. Chapter 63 opens with a figure coming from Edom in blood-stained garments, treading the winepress of wrath, and ends with a remembrance of God's saving acts in the exodus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The Spirit of the Lord GOD is upon me, because the LORD has anointed me to bring good news to the poor" (61:1).
2. "To proclaim liberty to the captives, and the opening of the prison to those who are bound" (61:1).
3. "To proclaim the year of the LORD's favor, and the day of vengeance of our God" (61:2).
4. "To grant to those who mourn in Zion… a beautiful headdress instead of ashes, the oil of gladness instead of mourning" (61:3).
5. "I will greatly rejoice in the LORD; my soul shall exult in my God, for he has clothed me with the garments of salvation" (61:10).
6. "You shall be called by a new name that the mouth of the LORD will give" (62:2).

7. “As the bridegroom rejoices over the bride, so shall your God rejoice over you” (62:5).
8. “In all their affliction he was afflicted, and the angel of his presence saved them; in his love and in his pity he redeemed them” (63:9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The speaker of chapter 61 is the Servant, now described as anointed with the Spirit. He is a prophet, a king, and a priest. His mission is a series of reversals: good news to the poor, binding up the brokenhearted, liberty for captives, comfort for those who mourn. The promise is of a jubilee, a year of release. The imagery is of the Year of Jubilee in Leviticus 25, when debts were forgiven and slaves went free. The beautiful exchanges are: a crown instead of ashes, gladness instead of mourning, a garment of praise instead of a faint spirit.

When Jesus read this passage in Nazareth, he stopped in the middle of verse 2, after “the year of the LORD’s favor.” He omitted the phrase “and the day of vengeance of our God.” Then he said, “Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing.” The first coming brings the favor, and the second will bring the vengeance. The two parts are separated by the time of the church.

Chapter 62 expresses God’s passion for his people. He will not keep silent until her righteousness shines like the dawn. She will be called by a new name, “My Delight Is in Her.” “As the bridegroom rejoices over the bride, so shall your God rejoice over you.” This is the language of marriage, as in Hosea. The divine bridegroom delights in his people. Watchmen are posted on the walls who will give God no rest until he makes Jerusalem a praise in the earth.

Chapter 63 begins with a terrifying warrior coming from Edom. His garments are stained red, for he has trodden the winepress alone. It is a picture of God’s judgment on his enemies. Then the prophet looks back with gratitude and prays, remembering the exodus. “In all their affliction he was afflicted.” God suffers with his people. But they rebelled and grieved his Holy Spirit. Even so, the Spirit led them, “like livestock that go down into the valley,” to give them rest.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus announced in Luke 4:18-21 that Isaiah 61 was fulfilled in him. He answered John the Baptist with these signs (Luke 7:22). Matthew 5:4 says, “Blessed are those who mourn, for they shall be comforted.” Ephesians 5:25-27 shows Christ as the bridegroom who presents the

church to himself in splendor. Revelation 19:13-15 draws on the warrior with the stained garment, and verse 7 speaks of the marriage of the Lamb. Ephesians 4:30 echoes “do not grieve the Holy Spirit.”

STEP 6

Application

Read Isaiah 61:1-3 as a description of your calling in Christ, and see where you can bring good news to someone who is poor, broken, or bound.

Receive the exchange: ask Jesus to give you a crown instead of ashes and the oil of gladness instead of mourning.

Rest in the truth that God rejoices over you, as a bridegroom over a bride.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for bringing good news to the poor and binding up the brokenhearted.
- Tell him what you want him to bind up in you.
- Thank him for the year of favor.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 60

“Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!”

ISAIAH 6:3

DAY 416 · WEEK 60

Isaiah 63:15-66:24

Lament and prayer; new creation, the grand finale

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Isaiah 63:15-66:24. The book ends with a desperate prayer for God to tear open the heavens, an answer that announces a new heavens and a new earth, and a final scene of worship and warning. Read chapter 65 slowly. It is the great finale of the book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The last part of Isaiah opens with one of the most heartfelt prayers in the Old Testament. The people confess their sin, plead for God to act, and ask for the heavens to be torn open. God replies with a promise of new creation, a place where the LORD's people live in peace and joy, with long life and no tears. The book closes with a contrast between those who tremble at God's word and those who do not.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For you are our Father, though Abraham does not know us, and Israel does not acknowledge us; you, O LORD, are our Father, our Redeemer from of old is your name" (63:16).
2. "Oh that you would rend the heavens and come down, that the mountains might quake at your presence" (64:1).
3. "We have all become like one who is unclean, and all our righteous deeds are like a polluted garment" (64:6).
4. "But now, O LORD, you are our Father; we are the clay, and you are our potter; we are all the work of your hand" (64:8).
5. "Before they call I will answer; while they are yet speaking I will hear" (65:24).

6. “For behold, I create new heavens and a new earth, and the former things shall not be remembered or come into mind” (65:17).
7. “No more shall there be in it an infant who lives but a few days” (65:20).
8. “But this is the one to whom I will look: he who is humble and contrite in spirit and trembles at my word” (66:2).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The prayer of 63:15 to 64:12 is the plea of a people who feel far from God. They look back to the exodus and ask where God’s zeal has gone. “You, O LORD, are our Father.” Their earthly fathers may not know them, but God does. They confess that they have strayed: “Why, O LORD, do you make us wander from your ways and harden our heart?” And the prayer climbs toward a cry: “Oh that you would rend the heavens and come down!” They want God to appear as he did at Sinai.

Then comes the confession of 64:6: “We have all become like one who is unclean, and all our righteous deeds are like a polluted garment.” It is a startling statement. Even our best deeds, apart from God, are stained. No one calls on his name or rouses himself to take hold of God. And then the prayer rests on a relationship: “But now, O LORD, you are our Father; we are the clay, and you are our potter.” If God shapes us, we can trust the shaping.

God’s answer in chapter 65 begins with a rebuke, because he was ready to be sought by a people who did not ask. “I said, Here am I, here am I, to a nation that was not called by my name.” Yet he will preserve a remnant, his servants, who will inherit. And the grand promise: “I create new heavens and a new earth.” The vision includes Jerusalem as a joy, with no weeping, no early deaths, no frustrated labor. “They shall build houses and inhabit them; they shall plant vineyards and eat their fruit.” The wolf and the lamb feed together again.

Chapter 66 emphasizes humility. The temple cannot contain God, and he looks to the one who is humble and contrite and trembles at his word. The book ends with a vision of all nations coming to worship, and a sober picture of the fate of rebels. “All flesh shall come to worship before me.” The last note is a warning, so that the reader will choose well.

STEP 5

Connection

Mark 1:10 describes the heavens being torn open at Jesus’ baptism, an answer to Isaiah 64:1. Romans 10:20-21 quotes Isaiah 65:1-2 about God’s welcome to the Gentiles. 2 Peter 3:13 and Revelation 21:1-4 describe the new heavens and new earth, with God dwelling with his

people and wiping away every tear. Romans 9:21 draws on the potter and the clay. Philippians 3:9 says our righteousness comes from God by faith. Jesus quotes Isaiah 66:24 in Mark 9:48.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Isaiah 64:8 as your own: “You are the potter; I am the clay.” Ask him to keep shaping you.

Consider where you still depend on your “righteous deeds.” Rest in Christ’s righteousness.

Meditate on the new creation. Ask God to make you long for it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Call on God as Father and Redeemer.
- Confess that your righteous deeds are like a polluted garment, and tell him whom you trust.
- Thank him for the new heavens and new earth.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 60

“Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!”

ISAIAH 6:3

DAY 417 · WEEK 60

Nahum 1:1-3:19

Nineveh falls, God's patience exhausted

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Nahum 1:1-3:19. Nahum is a short prophecy of about fifty verses against Nineveh, the Assyrian capital. This is the same city that repented under Jonah. Read it with Jonah in mind, and ask what has changed.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Nahum prophesied in the seventh century BC, sometime after the fall of Thebes in 663 BC and before the fall of Nineveh in 612 BC. A hundred and fifty years earlier, Nineveh had repented at Jonah's preaching. In the generations since, the city returned to violence and cruelty and became the capital of the empire that destroyed Samaria and tormented Judah. Nahum's message is that God's patience, though long, has an end.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD is a jealous and avenging God; the LORD is avenging and wrathful" (1:2).
2. "The LORD is slow to anger and great in power, and the LORD will by no means clear the guilty" (1:3).
3. "The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble; he knows those who take refuge in him" (1:7).
4. "Behold, on the mountains, the feet of him who brings good news, who publishes peace!" (1:15).
5. "Woe to the bloody city, all full of lies and plunder" (3:1).
6. "Behold, I am against you, declares the LORD of hosts" (3:5).
7. "There is no easing your hurt; your wound is grievous" (3:19).

8 “For upon whom has not come your unceasing evil?” (3:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book opens with a majestic hymn about God’s character, drawing on Exodus 34:6-7. But Nahum emphasizes a different side. He quotes “slow to anger” and then, “will by no means clear the guilty.” God’s patience is not indifference. A holy God must respond to evil. The imagery is of a storm: mountains quake, hills melt, the earth heaves. Who can stand before his indignation? And in the middle, a note of gentle comfort: “The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble; he knows those who take refuge in him.” To the same God, the wicked experience a fire, and the faithful a refuge. Everything depends on which side of him we stand.

The word to Judah in 1:12-15 is a comfort: “Though I have afflicted you, I will afflict you no more.” The yoke of Assyria will be broken. And the herald appears on the mountains with good news. Isaiah 52:7 uses the same image, which Paul applies to the preaching of the gospel in Romans 10:15.

Chapters 2 and 3 describe the fall of Nineveh with vivid military imagery: shields red, chariots flashing, the river gates opening, the palace dissolving. In 612 BC, the city fell when the Tigris flooded and broke part of the wall, and the Babylonians and Medes entered. The prophet describes the city as a den of lions that fed on prey and filled its caves with plunder. “Behold, I am against you.” Her sins are violence, deceit, plunder, and sorceries. She will be exposed, shamed, and no one will mourn.

The book ends with a rhetorical question that reminds us of Jonah: “For upon whom has not come your unceasing evil?” The contrast with the book of Jonah is a lesson. In Jonah’s day, the city repented and was spared. In Nahum’s day, the city had returned to evil and was not spared. God’s mercy is real, and God’s justice is real. Both come from the same character. No generation can live on the repentance of a previous one.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 11:22 says, “Note then the kindness and the severity of God.” Romans 10:15 applies Nahum 1:15 to those who bring the gospel. Jesus’ comparison in Matthew 12:41 says the men of Nineveh will rise at the judgment. 2 Peter 3:9 says the Lord is patient, not wishing that any should perish, and verse 10 says the day of the Lord will come. Hebrews 12:29 says our God is a consuming fire. Psalm 34:8 invites us to taste and see that the LORD is good.

STEP 6

Application

Take refuge in the LORD, who is good, and thank him that you are known by him.

Ask whether you are presuming on God's patience in any area.

Pray for a violent or oppressive regime in the world today, that justice would come and the oppressed would be freed.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is slow to anger and great in power.

Thank him that he is a stronghold and knows those who take refuge in him.

Pray for those who suffer under cruelty.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 60

"Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!"

ISAIAH 6:3

DAY 418 · WEEK 60

Habakkuk 1:1-3:19

The just shall live by faith, wrestling with God's ways

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Habakkuk 1:1-3:19. Habakkuk does something unusual for a prophet: he argues with God. Read it as a conversation. Notice how the prophet's questions change, and where the book ends.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Habakkuk prophesied in Judah around 610 to 600 BC, probably in the days of King Jehoiakim, when the Assyrian empire was collapsing and Babylon was rising. Judah was full of violence and injustice. Habakkuk cries out to God, and God's answer disturbs him even more. The book is a dialogue between a troubled believer and a sovereign God. It ends with one of the greatest expressions of faith in the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, how long shall I cry for help, and you will not hear? Or cry to you Violence! and you will not save?" (1:2).
2. "Look among the nations, and see; wonder and be astounded. For I am doing a work in your days that you would not believe if told" (1:5).
3. "For behold, I am raising up the Chaldeans" (1:6).
4. "You who are of purer eyes than to see evil and cannot look at wrong, why do you idly look at traitors?" (1:13).
5. "I will take my stand at my watchpost... and look out to see what he will say to me" (2:1).
6. "Behold, his soul is puffed up; it is not upright within him, but the righteous shall live by his faith" (2:4).

7. “For the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD as the waters cover the sea” (2:14).

8. “Though the fig tree should not blossom… yet I will rejoice in the LORD; I will take joy in the God of my salvation” (3:17-18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Habakkuk’s first complaint is that God is silent in the face of violence in Judah. God answers that he is raising up the Chaldeans, the Babylonians, a fierce and dreadful nation. This is not the answer Habakkuk wanted. He asks a second question: How can a holy God use a nation more wicked than Judah to punish them? “You who are of purer eyes than to see evil… why do you look at traitors and remain silent when the wicked swallows up the man more righteous than he?” It is an honest, hard question about God’s justice and his ways.

Habakkuk then takes his stand like a watchman and waits. God replies, and tells him to write the vision plainly. It will surely come, though it seems slow. And at the center of the answer is the verse that changed history: “The righteous shall live by his faith.” The proud, puffed-up man depends on himself. The righteous person depends on God, and lives by trust in him, even when the answer seems to be delay.

The rest of chapter 2 contains five woes against the Babylonians, those who plunder, build their house by injustice, build cities with blood, make others drunk, and trust in idols. They will fall. “But the LORD is in his holy temple; let all the earth keep silence before him.” It is a verse that stills the questions.

Chapter 3 is a prayer, set to music, that recalls God’s great acts in the exodus and at Sinai. Habakkuk sees God coming in splendor, with light and pestilence. He trembles. And then comes the glorious conclusion: “Though the fig tree should not blossom, nor fruit be on the vines… yet I will rejoice in the LORD.” He lists every kind of agricultural disaster, a picture of complete economic collapse. And still he rejoices. Faith does not depend on circumstances. “God, the Lord, is my strength; he makes my feet like the deer’s; he makes me tread on my high places.” The prophet who began in doubt ends in joy.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Habakkuk 2:4 in Romans 1:17 and Galatians 3:11, and the author of Hebrews quotes it in Hebrews 10:38. It became the foundation text of the Reformation. Habakkuk 2:14 echoes Isaiah 11:9. Romans 8:28 and 8:35-39 give a New Testament answer to Habakkuk’s questions: nothing can separate us from the love of God. Philippians 4:11-13 shows Paul’s contentment in every circumstance. James 1:2-4 calls us to count it joy when we meet trials.

STEP 6

Application

Bring your hardest question to God in prayer. Habakkuk shows that honest questions are welcome.

Take your “stand at the watchpost.” Set aside time to listen after you have prayed.

Write out your own version of Habakkuk 3:17-18, naming real things that could be taken from you, and say you will still rejoice in the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring God your honest questions.
- Ask him to teach you to live by faith.
- Tell him you will rejoice in him even when things are barren.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 60

“Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!”

ISAIAH 6:3

DAY 419 · WEEK 60

Zephaniah 1:1-3:20

The Day of the LORD; the LORD rejoices over his people

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Zephaniah 1:1-3:20. The last of this unit's prophets begins with a terrifying announcement of the Day of the LORD and ends with one of the most tender images of God in the Bible. Read the last four verses twice.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Zephaniah prophesied in the days of King Josiah, around 640 to 609 BC, before Josiah's reforms took hold. His great-grandfather was Hezekiah, so he may have been of royal blood. The book is built around the phrase "the day of the LORD." It begins with a universal judgment, calls Judah to repent, speaks against the nations, and ends with restoration. It prepares the way for the exile that is coming.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will utterly sweep away everything from the face of the earth, declares the LORD" (1:2).
2. "The great day of the LORD is near, near and hastening fast" (1:14).
3. "Seek the LORD, all you humble of the land, who do his just commands; seek righteousness; seek humility; perhaps you may be hidden on the day of the anger of the LORD" (2:3).
4. "Woe to her who is rebellious and defiled, the oppressing city!" (3:1).
5. "She listens to no voice; she accepts no correction. She does not trust in the LORD; she does not draw near to her God" (3:2).

6. “For at that time I will change the speech of the peoples to a pure speech, that all of them may call upon the name of the LORD” (3:9).

7. “But I will leave in your midst a people humble and lowly. They shall seek refuge in the name of the LORD” (3:12).

8. “The LORD your God is in your midst, a mighty one who will save; he will rejoice over you with gladness; he will quiet you by his love; he will exult over you with loud singing” (3:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first chapter is relentless. God will sweep away everything: man and beast, birds and fish. The reason is idolatry and spiritual indifference. The people worship Baal and the host of heaven, and others say in their hearts, “The LORD will not do good, nor will he do ill.” They are practical atheists who believe that God does nothing. God will search Jerusalem with lamps. The day is described as a day of wrath, distress, ruin, darkness, and gloom. Not even silver or gold can deliver them.

Then chapter 2 begins with a call: “Gather yourselves together… before the decree takes effect… seek the LORD, all you humble of the land.” The only protection is humility and a search for righteousness. “Perhaps you may be hidden.” The word “perhaps” reminds us that no one deserves to be saved. Yet the invitation is real. The remaining part of the chapter pronounces judgment on Philistia, Moab, Ammon, Cush, and Assyria. Nineveh will be a desolation.

Chapter 3 returns to Jerusalem, “the oppressing city,” which did not listen or trust. Officials are roaring lions, judges evening wolves, prophets reckless and treacherous, priests profane the sanctuary. “The LORD within her is righteous; he does no injustice.” God had hoped that she would learn, but she was eager to make her deeds corrupt.

And then the turn, “For at that time.” The nations will call on the name of the LORD. A humble and lowly remnant will be left, who do no injustice and speak no lies. They will lie down with none to make them afraid. Then the song: “Sing aloud, O daughter of Zion.” The reason is verse 17, one of the most beautiful verses in the Old Testament. The LORD is in your midst, a warrior who saves. He rejoices over you with gladness. “He will quiet you by his love.” He sings over you. The God who judged is the God who sings. The same hand that sweeps away the proud gathers the humble.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the one in the midst of his people who saves (Matthew 1:21; 18:20). Romans 8:1 says there is no condemnation for those in Christ, who have been hidden on the day of wrath. Luke 15:5-7 and 15:20-24 show heaven rejoicing over sinners who return. Hebrews 12:22-24 describes the gathered assembly of the firstborn. Revelation 7:9-17 shows the multitude from every nation, with God wiping away tears. 1 Thessalonians 1:10 says Jesus delivers us from the wrath to come.

STEP 6

Application

Read Zephaniah 3:17 aloud, replacing "you" with your own name, and sit in it for a few minutes.

Ask whether you ever live as if "the LORD will not do good, nor will he do ill," as a practical atheist.

Pray for humility, the posture that Zephaniah says leads to being hidden.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to hide you in the day of his anger.
- Tell him you seek righteousness and humility.
- Thank him that he rejoices over you with singing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 60

"Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!"

ISAIAH 6:3

DAY 420 · WEEK 60

Review and Sabbath Rest

Unit 12 review, Hezekiah, Isaiah & the Assyrian Crisis

Year 1 · Unit 12 · Review and Sabbath

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!"
>
> ISAIAH 6:3

REST

Meditation

This is the cry of the seraphim in Isaiah's vision, and it is the anchor of the whole unit. Everything you have read, from the vineyard song to the suffering Servant to the fall of Nineveh, flows from who God is. He is holy.

"Holy, holy, holy." Hebrew has no way to say "more" or "most." Instead it repeats. To say a word three times is to say it as strongly as language can. Only this one attribute of God is ever repeated three times in the Bible. He is utterly set apart, in power, in purity, and in glory. All other things that we call holy are holy because they are connected to him.

"Is the LORD of hosts." The holy one is not an abstract force. He is the LORD, the covenant God who has a name and who keeps promises. He is also the Lord of hosts, the commander of the armies of heaven. The one who stands against Assyria is the one who reigns over every power.

"The whole earth is full of his glory." The seraphim see glory in every corner of creation. God's glory is not limited to the temple. It fills the whole earth. Later in Isaiah, we learn that the knowledge of that glory will cover the earth as the waters cover the sea, and that all flesh will see it together.

Say this verse from memory, and let it shape how you approach God. The holy God has also become your Savior. He sent a seraph with a coal, and, in Christ, he removed your guilt. The one who is holy has made a way for you to stand before him. He calls us to say with the seraphim, and with all creation, "Holy, holy, holy."

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the book of Isaiah and the prophets of the Assyrian crisis. You read about the fast God chooses, the Spirit-anointed one whom Jesus identified as himself, and the great prayer asking God to tear open the heavens. You read God's answer of a new creation, where the wolf and the lamb feed together and sorrow is no more. You then read three short books: Nahum, which announced the fall of the city that once repented; Habakkuk, who argued with God and learned to live by faith, and who rejoiced in the LORD though everything failed; and Zephaniah, who warned of the Day of the LORD and ended with God exulting over his people with loud singing. The week taught that God is holy and just, that faith is the way to live in uncertain times, and that the God who judges is the God who saves.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

This unit covered one of the most important periods in Old Testament history and one of the greatest books of prophecy. King Hezekiah trusted the LORD when Assyria surrounded Jerusalem, spread Sennacherib's letter before him, and saw 185,000 soldiers struck down in a night. Isaiah, who prophesied through the crisis, saw the Lord high and lifted up, heard the cry of "Holy, holy, holy," was cleansed and sent, and announced Immanuel, the child born to us, and the shoot from Jesse's stump. Chapters 40 to 55 gave comfort to exiles and introduced the Servant, who was despised and rejected, pierced for our transgressions, and yet exalted. You paused on the doctrine of the atonement. Chapters 56 to 66 closed with the invitation to everyone who thirsts, the Spirit-anointed herald, and the promise of new heavens and a new earth. Nahum showed that God's patience with Nineveh ended, Habakkuk taught that the righteous shall live by faith, and Zephaniah ended with the God who sings over his people.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does Isaiah's vision of God in chapter 6 teach about worship?

Think about the order of the vision: God's holiness, Isaiah's confession, the cleansing coal, and the call to go. What does each step show about how we come before God, and how does the vision change a person?

Who is the Servant in Isaiah 40-55, and what does he do?

Look at the four Servant Songs (42:1-4, 49:1-6, 50:4-9, 52:13-53:12). Consider his calling, his gentleness, his obedience, and his mission to the nations. How does the New Testament say Jesus fulfills this role (Matthew 12:15-21; Acts 8:32-35)?

How does Isaiah 53 describe substitutionary atonement?

Notice the repeated words “our” and “his.” Write a few sentences about what the Servant bore, why he bore it, and what the result is for those who trust in him. Compare with Romans 3:21-26 and 1 Peter 2:24.

What does “the righteous shall live by his faith” mean in Habakkuk’s context?

Recall the dilemma: injustice in Judah, Babylon coming as a rod, and God’s silence. What does it mean to live by faith when the answer is delayed? Consider Habakkuk 3:17-19 and how Paul uses the verse in Romans 1:17.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the Servant who was pierced for your transgressions.

Thank him for what he has taught you through Isaiah and the prophets.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 13 · DAYS 421-495

Exile: Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel

Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel

Judgment falls. But God promises a New Covenant written on the heart.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts."

JEREMIAH 31:33

Laments of exile (89:38-52, 137, 79), songs of hope (85, 102, 103, 106, 107), and ten of the fifteen Songs of Ascents.

UNIT 13

In this unit

WEEK 61

421	2 Kings 21:1-23:37	*Reading*
422	2 Kings 24:1-25:30	*Reading*
423	Psalm 89:38-52	*Psalm*
424	Psalm 137	*Psalm*
425	Jeremiah 1:1-3:5	*Reading*
426	Jeremiah 3:6-6:30	*Reading*
427	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 62

428	Jeremiah 7:1-9:26	*Reading*
429	Psalm 79	*Psalm*
430	Psalm 85	*Psalm*
431	Jeremiah 10:1-13:27	*Reading*
432	Jeremiah 14:1-17:27	*Reading*
433	Jeremiah 18:1-20:18	*Reading*
434	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 63

435	Psalm 102	*Psalm*
436	Psalm 103	*Psalm*
437	Jeremiah 21:1-24:10	*Reading*
438	Jeremiah 25:1-27:22	*Reading*
439	Jeremiah 28:1-29:32	*Reading*
440	Psalm 106	*Psalm*
441	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 64

442	Psalm 107:1-22	*Psalm*

443	Jeremiah 30:1-31:40	*Reading*
444	Jeremiah 32:1-33:26	*Reading*
445	Jeremiah 34:1-36:32	*Reading*
446	Jeremiah 37:1-39:18	*Reading*
447	Psalm 107:23-43	*Psalm*
448	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 65

449	Psalm 108	*Psalm*
450	Jeremiah 40:1-42:22	*Reading*
451	Jeremiah 43:1-45:5	*Reading*
452	Jeremiah 46:1-48:47	*Reading*
453	Jeremiah 49:1-51:64	*Reading*
454	Jeremiah 52:1-34	*Reading*
455	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 66

456	Psalm 119:145-176	*Psalm*
457	Psalm 120; Psalm 121	*Psalm*
458	Lamentations 1:1-2:22	*Reading*
459	Lamentations 3:1-66	*Reading*
460	Lamentations 4:1-5:22	*Reading*
461	Ezekiel 1:1-3:27	*Reading*
462	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 67

463	Psalm 73	*Psalm*
464	Psalm 77	*Psalm*
465	Ezekiel 4:1-7:27	*Reading*
466	Ezekiel 8:1-11:25	*Reading*
467	Ezekiel 12:1-14:23	*Reading*
468	Ezekiel 15:1-17:24	*Reading*

469	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 68

470	Psalm 122	*Psalm*
471	Psalm 123; Psalm 126	*Psalm*
472	Ezekiel 18:1-20:49	*Reading*
473	Ezekiel 21:1-24:27	*Reading*
474	Ezekiel 25:1-28:26	*Reading*
475	Ezekiel 29:1-32:32	*Reading*
476	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 69

477	Psalm 128; Psalm 129	*Psalm*
478	Psalm 131; Psalm 133; Psalm 134	*Psalm*
479	Ezekiel 33:1-35:15	*Reading*
480	Ezekiel 36:1-37:28	*Reading*
481	Ezekiel 38:1-39:29	*Reading*
482	Ezekiel 40:1-43:27	*Reading*
483	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 70

484	Ezekiel 44:1-46:24	*Reading*
485	Ezekiel 47:1-48:35	*Reading*
486	Daniel 1:1-2:49	*Reading*
487	Daniel 3:1-4:37	*Reading*
488	Psalm 135	*Psalm*
489	Psalm 136	*Psalm*
490	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 71

491	Daniel 5:1-6:28	*Reading*
492	Daniel 7:1-8:27	*Reading*
493	Daniel 9:1-10:21	*Reading*

494	Daniel 11:1-12:13	*Reading*
495	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 421 · WEEK 61

2 Kings 21:1-23:37

Manasseh; Josiah's reform; the Book of the Law found

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 95 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 21:1-23:37. Judah's worst king is followed by one of its best, and yet the judgment does not turn back. Read chapter 22 slowly, and notice what happens when the Book of the Law is found.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This unit begins the last chapter of Judah's story. Manasseh reigned fifty-five years, the longest of any king, and the Bible calls his reign the cause of Judah's fall. His grandson Josiah then led the greatest reform in the nation's history, and still the sentence of exile stood. Jeremiah began to prophesy in Josiah's thirteenth year, so the prophet you are about to meet stands inside this story.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Manasseh "did what was evil in the sight of the LORD, according to the despicable practices of the nations" (21:2).
2. He "burned his son as an offering" and "shed very much innocent blood" (21:6, 16).
3. "I am bringing such disaster upon Jerusalem and Judah that the ears of everyone who hears of it will tingle" (21:12).
4. Josiah "did what was right in the eyes of the LORD" at eight years old (22:1-2).
5. "I have found the Book of the Law in the house of the LORD" (22:8).
6. "When the king heard the words of the Book of the Law, he tore his clothes" (22:11).
7. "Because your heart was tender and you humbled yourself before the LORD… I also have heard you" (22:19).

8 “Before him there was no king like him, who turned to the LORD with all his heart… Still the LORD did not turn from the burning of his great anger” (23:25-26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Manasseh rebuilt the high places, set up altars to the host of heaven inside the temple courts, practiced sorcery, and sacrificed his own son. The writer says he led the people astray to do more evil than the nations God had destroyed before Israel. The sentence given in chapter 21 is clear: Jerusalem will be wiped out like a dish turned upside down.

Then Josiah. When the Book of the Law is found during temple repairs, it has been lost so long that its words come as a shock. The king hears it read and tears his clothes. This is the right response to Scripture: not curiosity but fear and humility. God tells him that judgment will come, but not in his days, because his heart was tender.

Josiah then does everything the book requires. He reads it to all the people and renews the covenant. He tears down the high places, destroys the altars, defiles Topheth where children were burned, and keeps the greatest Passover since the judges. The writer gives him the highest praise: no king turned to the LORD with all his heart, soul, and might like him.

And yet. “Still the LORD did not turn from the burning of his great anger.” Reform could slow the judgment but could not undo a generation’s habits. The people had cleaned the house, but their hearts had not changed. That is the problem the rest of this unit will face, and why Jeremiah will promise a covenant written on the heart. Josiah dies at Megiddo in 609 BC, and within a few years the nation is under Egypt and then Babylon.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus rebuked leaders who “neglect the weightier matters of the law” (Matthew 23:23). Hebrews 8:7-13 says that the first covenant was faulty because the people did not continue in it, and quotes Jeremiah’s promise of a new one. Romans 7:7-25 shows the law exposing sin without being able to change the heart. Luke 4:17 shows Jesus finding the scroll of Isaiah and reading, a better finding of the Word.

STEP 6

Application

Open your Bible today as if you had just found it. Ask what you would do if you really heard it.

Consider whether you have been tidying up outward habits while your heart stays the same.

Pray for a tender heart, one that trembles at God's word.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to make you tremble at his word as Josiah did.
- Ask him not to let you settle for outward reform.
- Confess where your heart has been hard.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 61

"For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water."

JEREMIAH 2:13

DAY 422 · WEEK 61

2 Kings 24:1-25:30

Jerusalem falls; the exile, covenant curses fulfilled

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 24:1-25:30. This is the end of the kingdom of Judah. Read it as the fulfillment of the covenant curses you saw in Deuteronomy, and look for the small sign of hope in the last verses.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After Josiah's death, Judah's last four kings ruled for about twenty-three years under the shadow of Egypt and Babylon. Nebuchadnezzar took the first exiles, including Daniel and Ezekiel, in 605 and 597 BC. The final siege ended in 586 BC, when Jerusalem and the temple were burned. This chapter is the historical backdrop for all the prophets you will read in this unit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Surely this came upon Judah at the command of the LORD, to remove them out of his sight" (24:3).
2. Nebuchadnezzar carried off "all Jerusalem… ten thousand captives" in 597 BC (24:14).
3. Zedekiah "rebelled against the king of Babylon" (24:20).
4. "On the seventh day of the fifth month… Nebuzaradan… burned the house of the LORD and the king's house and all the houses of Jerusalem" (25:8-9).
5. They killed Zedekiah's sons before his eyes and then blinded him (25:7).
6. The bronze pillars, the sea, and the temple vessels were broken up and carried to Babylon (25:13-17).
7. "So Judah was taken into exile out of its land" (25:21).

8 “Evil-merodach king of Babylon… graciously freed Jehoiachin from prison… and Jehoiachin dined regularly at the king’s table” (25:27-29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The story is told with terrible plainness. The writer does not shout or linger. He lists the steps: the siege, the famine, the breach in the wall, the flight of the king, the burning of the temple, the stripping of the bronze, the deportation. The curses of Deuteronomy 28 have come true in order. The nation that was brought out of Egypt is carried back into foreign captivity.

The blame is placed squarely on Judah’s sin, and especially Manasseh’s. But the Lord is the one who sends the Babylonians. This is a point the prophets will make again and again: Babylon is God’s instrument, not his master. Exile is not a sign that God lost. It is a sign that God keeps his word.

Notice the loss of everything that Judah trusted in. The temple is destroyed, which they believed could never fall. The king is blinded and bound. The land is emptied. The articles of worship are melted down. There is nothing left to stand on except God himself.

And then the last four verses. After thirty-seven years in prison, Jehoiachin, the king of David’s line, is released and given a seat at Babylon’s table. It is a small thing. But it shows that David’s line is not extinct. The promise of 2 Samuel 7 has not been cancelled. The writer ends the book with a candle in the dark, and the prophets will light more.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 1:11-12 includes the exile in the genealogy of Jesus: “Jechoniah and his brothers, at the time of the deportation to Babylon.” Jesus predicted another fall of Jerusalem (Luke 21:20-24), and Hebrews 12:27-28 speaks of a kingdom that cannot be shaken. Romans 11:22 pairs God’s kindness and severity. Lamentations will give voice to this grief in a few days.

STEP 6

Application

Take a moment to sit with the weight of this chapter. Judgment is real, and God means what he says.

Ask what you have trusted in as unshakeable: a building, a position, a routine. Where does your security come from?

Remember the small candle at the end, and look for small signs of God's faithfulness in dark times.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to teach you to fear him and not presume on his patience.
- Ask him to hold you when everything is lost.
- Thank him that he keeps his word in judgment and mercy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 61

"For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water."

JEREMIAH 2:13

DAY 423 · WEEK 61

Psalm 89:38-52

You have renounced the covenant

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 15 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 89:38-52. Last unit you read the first half of this psalm, which celebrates God's covenant with David. Today comes the second half, which seems to contradict it. Read it as the prayer of someone living the fall of Jerusalem.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 89 changes in verse 38. After thirty-seven verses of praise for God's oath to David, the psalmist turns and says, "But now you have cast off and rejected." The king is humiliated, the crown is in the dust, the walls are broken. This is the psalm that fits the end of 2 Kings: the line of David has fallen, and the promise seems to have failed.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But now you have cast off and rejected; you are full of wrath against your anointed" (v. 38).
2. "You have renounced the covenant with your servant; you have defiled his crown in the dust" (v. 39).
3. "You have breached all his walls; you have laid his strongholds in ruins" (v. 40).
4. "You have not made him stand in battle" (v. 43).
5. "You have cut short the days of his youth; you have covered him with shame" (v. 45).
6. "How long, O LORD? Will you hide yourself forever? How long will your wrath burn like fire?" (v. 46).
7. "Lord, where is your steadfast love of old, which by your faithfulness you swore to David?" (v. 49).

8 “Blessed be the LORD forever! Amen and Amen” (v. 52).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The contrast between the two halves is deliberate and honest. The first half quotes God’s oath: “I will not violate my covenant.” The second half describes what it looks like to live as though God had violated it. The psalmist does not pretend that the promise and the experience match. He says, “You have renounced the covenant.” It is the language of a person who is not hiding his confusion.

Yet he does not walk away. Every complaint is addressed to God. That is the mark of faith in this psalm: the very God who seems to have broken his word is the one the psalmist keeps speaking to. “Lord, where is your steadfast love of old, which by your faithfulness you swore to David?” He holds God to his own promise.

The ending is one of the most surprising in the Psalter. After forty verses of lament, the psalm closes with praise: “Blessed be the LORD forever! Amen and Amen.” This is a doxology that marks the end of Book 3. Nothing has been resolved. The question is still open. But the psalmist blesses God anyway. Sometimes faith is the choice to bless when you cannot see how the story will end.

For Israel, the answer was long in coming. The line of David looked dead for six hundred years. But the answer came in Bethlehem, in a son of David who would never be removed.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 13:32-34 says that God fulfilled the promise to David by raising Jesus from the dead. Luke 1:32-33 announces that the Lord will give him the throne of his father David. Romans 1:3-4 says Jesus was descended from David according to the flesh and declared Son of God by the resurrection. Revelation 5:5 says the Lion of Judah, the Root of David, has conquered. Romans 15:13 prays for hope in the God of hope.

STEP 6

Application

When your experience does not match God’s promise, pray as the psalmist did: honestly, and to God.

Choose to bless the LORD even in an unanswered season. Say “Blessed be the LORD forever” aloud.

Thank God for Jesus, the answer to the question of Psalm 89.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God where his steadfast love is, in your own honest words.

Bring him your questions because you have nowhere else to go.

Bless him even in the hard questions.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 61

"For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water."

JEREMIAH 2:13

DAY 424 · WEEK 61

Psalm 137

By the waters of Babylon we sat down and wept

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 137. It is the most famous psalm of the exile. Read it slowly. It begins with tears and ends with a prayer that is hard to read. Ask why it is in the Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 137 was written by someone who had been to Babylon. The exiles sat beside the canals of the Euphrates, and their captors asked them to sing the songs of Zion for entertainment. The psalm is about memory, grief, and the burning of anger. It was probably written after the return, as the memory was still raw. It is paired here with the end of the kingdom.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “By the waters of Babylon, there we sat down and wept, when we remembered Zion” (v. 1).
2. “On the willows there we hung up our lyres” (v. 2).
3. “For there our captors required of us songs, and our tormentors, mirth” (v. 3).
4. “How shall we sing the LORD’s song in a foreign land?” (v. 4).
5. “If I forget you, O Jerusalem, let my right hand forget its skill!” (v. 5).
6. “Let my tongue stick to the roof of my mouth, if I do not remember you” (v. 6).
7. “Remember, O LORD, against the Edomites the day of Jerusalem” (v. 7).
8. “Blessed shall he be who takes your little ones and dashes them against the rock!” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a scene. The exiles sit by the river and weep. The lyres hang on the poplars. They cannot sing. The captors want songs of Zion as entertainment, and to do so would be to treat the worship of the living God as a performance. “How shall we sing the LORD’s song in a foreign land?” The question carries a deeper one: how can we worship when everything is gone?

The answer is memory. In verses 5 and 6 the singer vows to remember Jerusalem above his highest joy. This is not nostalgia. Jerusalem is where God has put his name. To forget Zion would be to forget God’s promises. The singer binds himself with a vow.

Then the psalm erupts in a cry for vengeance. He asks God to remember the Edomites, who cheered on the destruction. And he addresses Babylon with a curse that includes the killing of infants, in the same way that Babylon had treated others. This is shocking. It is a raw expression of the rage of the grieving, and it is there in Scripture without any softening.

Why is it in the Bible? Because honest prayer includes anger. The Bible does not tell us to hide our worst feelings from God. It gives us a place to pour them out. The psalmist does not take up a weapon. He lays the burning desire for justice before the one who will judge. We should not pray these words as our own wish for revenge, but they teach us that God can bear our rage, and that justice belongs to him. And they point us to the cross, where the justice we cannot execute was carried out in a way that included mercy.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 12:19 says, “Never avenge yourselves, but leave it to the wrath of God.” Jesus on the cross prayed, “Father, forgive them” (Luke 23:34). Revelation 18 shows the fall of Babylon the great, the answer to this psalm’s prayer. 1 Peter 2:11 calls Christians “sojourners and exiles.” Hebrews 13:14 says we seek the city that is to come. Philippians 3:20 says our citizenship is in heaven.

STEP 6

Application

Think about what you refuse to forget about God and his people. Name it.

If you carry anger over a wrong, bring it to God by name, without acting on it.

Pray for Christians who are in exile in a hostile place.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you grieve and what anger you carry.

Ask him to teach you to sing his song in a foreign land.

Hand your grief over to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 61

"For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water."

JEREMIAH 2:13

DAY 425 · WEEK 61

Jeremiah 1:1-3:5

Jeremiah called; the two evils; broken cisterns

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 1:1-3:5. Jeremiah is the longest book in the Bible by word count, and it is the story of a reluctant prophet. Read his call in chapter 1, and then notice the two evils that God names in chapter 2.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jeremiah was a priest from Anathoth, a village near Jerusalem. He was called as a young man in the thirteenth year of Josiah, around 627 BC, and he prophesied for over forty years, through the reform, the fall of Jerusalem, and the flight to Egypt. His message was unpopular. He was beaten, imprisoned, and thrown into a cistern. He is called the weeping prophet, but he was also a man of great courage.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Before I formed you in the womb I knew you, and before you were born I consecrated you; I appointed you a prophet to the nations” (1:5).
2. “Ah, Lord GOD! Behold, I do not know how to speak, for I am only a youth” (1:6).
3. “Do not say, I am only a youth; for to all to whom I send you, you shall go” (1:7).
4. “Behold, I have put my words in your mouth” (1:9).
5. “For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water” (2:13).
6. “What wrong did your fathers find in me that they went far from me?” (2:5).
7. “My people have changed their glory for that which does not profit” (2:11).

8 “Have you not just now called to me, My father, you are the friend of my youth?” (3:4).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jeremiah’s call is among the most intimate in Scripture. God says he knew him before he was formed. Before birth, he was set apart. The call is not an accident or a career. It is the purpose of his existence. Jeremiah objects at once: “I am only a youth.” God’s reply is typical: don’t say that. Go where I send you, speak what I command, and “be not afraid of them, for I am with you to deliver you.” God then touches his mouth. The word of the LORD is something God puts in the prophet.

His commission has two sides: “to pluck up and to break down, to destroy and to overthrow, to build and to plant.” Four verbs of judgment and two of restoration. Judgment comes first.

Chapter 2 is one of the great statements of sin in the Bible. God remembers the devotion of Israel’s youth, like a bride following him in the wilderness. Then he asks, “What wrong did your fathers find in me?” It is the question of a husband who cannot understand why his wife left. Then the two evils. First, they forsook the fountain of living waters. A spring is endless, fresh, and free. Second, they dug their own cisterns, cracked and leaking. Idolatry is both ingratitude and folly. The nations do not change their gods, and Israel has changed its glory for what does not profit.

The pattern is the human heart: to leave the source of life and then to spend all our energy on things that cannot hold what we put in them. Every generation digs cisterns. Money, approval, success, and pleasure are broken cisterns.

Yet the chapter ends with an invitation. God says, “Return.” The door is still open.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said to the woman at the well, “Whoever drinks of the water that I will give him will never be thirsty again” (John 4:14), and “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink” (John 7:37). Paul says he was set apart before he was born (Galatians 1:15). Matthew 16:14 notes that some thought Jesus was Jeremiah. Ephesians 2:10 says we are God’s workmanship, created for good works.

STEP 6

Application

Name one “broken cistern” that you have gone to for satisfaction. Bring your thirst to Christ.

If you have felt too young, too inexperienced, or too weak for what God has asked, hear his words, “I am with you.”

Pray for a fresh sense of being known and called by God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the cisterns you have dug for yourself.
- Ask him to draw you back to the fountain of living waters.
- Thank him that he knew you before you were formed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 61

“For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water.”

JEREMIAH 2:13

DAY 426 · WEEK 61

Jeremiah 3:6-6:30

Israel and Judah's unfaithfulness; the foe from the north

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 3:6-6:30. God calls two faithless sisters, Israel and Judah, to return, and then announces a foe from the north. Read the call to return in 3:12-4:4 slowly, and then notice how the people respond to the warning in chapter 6.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters belong to the early part of Jeremiah's ministry, in the days of Josiah. The northern kingdom had already been destroyed. Judah had seen what happened to her sister and had not learned. Jeremiah mixes pleading and warning. The enemy is a nation from the north, which is Babylon. The people were in the middle of Josiah's reform, and yet the prophet says that the heart has not changed.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Faithless Israel has shown herself more righteous than treacherous Judah" (3:11).
2. "Return, faithless Israel, declares the LORD. I will not look on you in anger, for I am merciful" (3:12).
3. "Return, O faithless sons; I will heal your faithlessness" (3:22).
4. "Circumcise yourselves to the LORD; remove the foreskin of your hearts" (4:4).
5. "My anguish, my anguish! I writhe in pain! Oh the walls of my heart!" (4:19).
6. "They are wise to do evil, but how to do good they know not" (4:22).
7. "They have healed the wound of my people lightly, saying, Peace, peace, when there is no peace" (6:14).

8 “Stand by the roads, and look, and ask for the ancient paths, where the good way is; and walk in it, and find rest for your souls. But they said, We will not walk in it” (6:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The call to return in chapter 3 is full of mercy. God compares Israel and Judah to two unfaithful wives. The northern kingdom had been sent away, and Judah had seen it and kept sinning, and with only a pretense of returning to God. Even so, he pleads: “Return, O faithless sons; I will heal your faithlessness.” The invitation contains the words to say, and the promise of shepherds after God’s own heart.

But the heart of chapter 4 is a demand for inward change: “Circumcise yourselves to the LORD; remove the foreskin of your hearts.” The outward sign of the covenant meant nothing if the heart remained closed. This is the main complaint of the prophets. Josiah could reform worship, but he could not circumcise the hearts of the nation.

Then the alarm. A lion has come up from his thicket. Jeremiah describes the invasion as if he were living it, and his own heart breaks. “My anguish, my anguish!” The prophet does not speak coldly about judgment. He feels it in his body. He is a true intercessor, identifying with the people he warns.

Chapter 6 identifies the problem. The leaders have “healed the wound of my people lightly, saying, Peace, peace, when there is no peace.” False comfort is cruel. They are not even ashamed of their abominations. God offers one more chance: “Stand by the roads, and look, and ask for the ancient paths… and find rest for your souls.” The answer is the saddest in the chapter: “We will not walk in it.” They are refusing an offer of rest.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest” (Matthew 11:28-29), alluding to Jeremiah 6:16. Paul says that real circumcision is of the heart, by the Spirit (Romans 2:28-29; Colossians 2:11). Jesus wept over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41), as Jeremiah wept. Hebrews 3:7-8 warns, “Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts.”

STEP 6

Application

Where do you hear “peace, peace” where there is no peace? Be honest about what needs to be dealt with.

Ask God for a circumcised heart, one that is open and responsive to him.

Look for an “ancient path” that you have neglected: Scripture, prayer, fellowship, Sabbath.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to circumcise your heart.

Keep yourself from false peace, and tell him where you want truth.

Thank him for promising to heal your faithlessness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 61

“For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water.”

JEREMIAH 2:13

DAY 427 · WEEK 61

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Jeremiah 2:13 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water."

JEREMIAH 2:13

REST

Meditation

God diagnoses the whole human problem in one verse, and he calls it two evils.

The first evil is leaving the fountain. God describes himself as "the fountain of living waters." In a dry land, a spring of living water is life. It does not run out or need to be dug. It simply flows. Every good thing we need comes from him, and he offers it freely. To forsake him is to walk away from the one source that cannot fail.

The second evil is building our own cisterns. A cistern is a hole cut in rock to collect rainwater. It is man-made, limited, and dependent on circumstances. And these are "broken" cisterns, cracked, so they cannot even hold what they collect. The picture is of tremendous effort invested in something that cannot deliver. We chisel away at success, approval, comfort, and control, and each time the water drains out.

What stands out is the tone. God is not only angry. He is astonished. Earlier in the chapter he says, “Be appalled, O heavens, at this.” It is baffling to him that anyone would trade a spring for a leaky tank. And behind the astonishment is grief. He loves his people and wants them to have what satisfies.

Jesus claimed to be this fountain. “Let the one who is thirsty come.” The remedy for broken cisterns is not trying harder but turning back. Say this verse when you feel empty, and ask what cistern you have been drinking from.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the exile unit by reading the last days of the kingdom of Judah. You saw Manasseh’s evil, Josiah’s tender-hearted reform, and the sobering line that the LORD still did not turn from his anger. You read the account of Jerusalem’s fall in 2 Kings, with the small candle of Jehoiachin’s release at the end. You prayed Psalm 89’s painful second half and the grief of Psalm 137, learning that honest prayer includes lament. And you met Jeremiah, called before he was born, who named the two evils of his people: forsaking the fountain of living waters and digging broken cisterns. His early preaching called them to return and to circumcise their hearts. The week taught that outward reform is not enough, that God invites us to return, and that he is the only source of life.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Josiah found the Book of the Law and tore his clothes. How do you respond when God’s word exposes something in your life?

Jeremiah describes forsaking the fountain and digging broken cisterns. What is one cistern you tend to drink from instead of God?

Jesus calls himself the source of living water (John 7:37-38). What would it look like to come to him as thirsty this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess the cisterns you have dug.

Thank Jesus for giving water that satisfies.

Rest in him today.

DAY 428 · WEEK 62

Jeremiah 7:1-9:26

The Temple sermon; false security condemned

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 87 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 7:1-9:26. Jeremiah stands in the gate of the temple and preaches the most dangerous sermon of his life. Read it as a warning to people who think that being near the right building makes them safe.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the Temple Sermon, delivered early in the reign of Jehoiakim, around 609 BC (see Jeremiah 26). The people believed that Jerusalem could never fall because the temple of the LORD was there. After the Assyrian army was destroyed in Hezekiah's day, that belief hardened into superstition. Jeremiah tells them it is a lie. Chapters 8 and 9 add the prophet's tears over the nation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Do not trust in these deceptive words: This is the temple of the LORD, the temple of the LORD, the temple of the LORD" (7:4).
2. "If you truly amend your ways and your deeds… if you do not oppress the sojourner, the fatherless, or the widow" (7:5-6).
3. "Has this house, which is called by my name, become a den of robbers in your eyes?" (7:11).
4. "Go now to my place that was in Shiloh… and see what I did to it" (7:12).
5. "For in the day that I brought them out of the land of Egypt, I did not speak to your fathers… concerning burnt offerings and sacrifices. But this command I gave them: Obey my voice" (7:22-23).

6. “Is there no balm in Gilead? Is there no physician there?” (8:22).
7. “Oh that my head were a spring of water, and my eyes a fountain of tears, that I might weep day and night” (9:1).
8. “Let not the wise man boast in his wisdom… but let him who boasts boast in this, that he understands and knows me” (9:23-24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sermon begins with a trap. The people repeat a slogan: “The temple of the LORD, the temple of the LORD, the temple of the LORD.” They treat the building as a charm. Jeremiah says that if they are going to live there, they must act justly: no oppression of the foreigner, the orphan, or the widow, no shedding of innocent blood, no following other gods. They steal, murder, commit adultery, swear falsely, and then come into the temple and say, “We are delivered!” That is, they think the temple frees them to keep doing evil.

God’s reply is that they have turned his house into “a den of robbers.” A den is where robbers hide after their crimes. Jesus quotes this very line when he clears the temple. Then God points to Shiloh, where the tabernacle once stood, and which had been destroyed. If he allowed that, he can allow this.

Verses 21 to 23 are a shock. God says that when he brought them out of Egypt, his main command was not about sacrifices but about obedience. The sacrifices were meant to express the relationship, not replace it.

Chapter 8 contains one of the most poignant questions in the Bible: “Is there no balm in Gilead?” Gilead was known for healing ointment. The prophet asks why his people are not healed, since there is a physician. The answer is that they will not be healed. And chapter 9 shows the prophet weeping. “Oh that my head were a spring of water.” He is the true intercessor.

The chapter ends with a great statement of what matters: let no one boast in wisdom, might, or riches, but in knowing the LORD, “who practices steadfast love, justice, and righteousness.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus quoted Jeremiah 7:11 when he cleansed the temple (Mark 11:17), and then said that not one stone would be left on another (Mark 13:2). Paul quotes Jeremiah 9:24 in 1 Corinthians 1:31 and 2 Corinthians 10:17. Jesus is the true physician (Mark 2:17). Acts 7:48 reminds us that

the Most High does not dwell in houses made by hands. 1 Corinthians 3:16 says that the believers are God's temple.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether any place, ritual, or tradition has become a "temple of the LORD" slogan for you.

Look at how you treat the foreigner, the orphan, and the widow. Is there something to change?

Memorize Jeremiah 9:23-24 and ask what you are tempted to boast in.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from trusting deceptive words.
- Ask him not to let you hide in his house while sin remains.
- Ask him to make you just and merciful toward the weak.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 62

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

DAY 429 · WEEK 62

Psalm 79

O God, the nations have come into your inheritance

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 79. It is a communal lament written after the destruction of Jerusalem. Read it as the congregation's cry after reading 2 Kings 25, and notice the way it moves from catastrophe to confession and to a request for forgiveness.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 79 is a psalm of Asaph. It is one of the clearest psalms about the Babylonian destruction of Jerusalem, with the temple defiled, the city in ruins, and the bodies unburied. It pairs naturally with Jeremiah's temple sermon, which warned this would happen. It is a prayer of those who know that part of the blame is their own.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O God, the nations have come into your inheritance; they have defiled your holy temple; they have laid Jerusalem in ruins" (v. 1).
2. "They have given the bodies of your servants to the birds of the heavens for food" (v. 2).
3. "We have become a taunt to our neighbors, mocked and derided by those around us" (v. 4).
4. "How long, O LORD? Will you be angry forever?" (v. 5).
5. "Do not remember against us our former iniquities; let your compassion come speedily to meet us, for we are brought very low" (v. 8).
6. "Help us, O God of our salvation, for the glory of your name" (v. 9).
7. "Why should the nations say, Where is their God?" (v. 10).

8 “But we your people, the sheep of your pasture, will give thanks to you forever; from generation to generation we will recount your praise” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with an inventory of ruin. The temple is defiled, the city is rubble, the dead are left unburied. The psalmist holds nothing back. The people have become a mockery to the neighbors, a taunt, and he asks the question every grieving believer asks: “How long, O LORD? Will you be angry forever?”

But notice what the prayer does not do. It does not claim that Judah is innocent. “Do not remember against us our former iniquities.” The people know why this happened. The prophets had told them. The psalm joins confession with the cry for help. “Help us… deliver us, and atone for our sins, for your name’s sake.” The word “atone” is the language of the temple, and it comes from a people who have lost their temple. They ask God himself to cover their sin.

The reason given for the appeal is God’s name. “Why should the nations say, Where is their God?” The people are not asking to be rescued because they deserve it, but because God’s reputation is bound up with theirs. This is the way of intercession in the Bible: to ask God to act for the sake of his own glory.

The psalm ends with a vow of praise. The people are “the sheep of your pasture.” The shepherd has allowed the wolves in, but the sheep still belong to him. They promise to give thanks forever and to tell the story from generation to generation. Even this psalm of ruin ends with testimony, since praise does not depend on circumstances.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus wept over Jerusalem and foretold its destruction (Luke 19:41-44). Hebrews 9:26 says Christ has appeared “to put away sin by the sacrifice of himself,” the atonement for which this psalm cries. 1 John 1:9 promises forgiveness to those who confess. John 10:11-16 shows Jesus as the shepherd who gathers his sheep. 1 Peter 2:25 says we have returned to the Shepherd.

STEP 6

Application

Practice confession as part of lament. Name your sins and ask God to atone for them.

Ask for God’s help for the sake of his name, not just your own comfort.

Tell someone younger the story of one thing God has done for you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help for the glory of his name.
- Ask him not to remember your former iniquities.
- Ask him to let his compassion come to meet you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 62

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

DAY 430 · WEEK 62

Psalm 85

LORD, you were favorable to your land

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 85. It is a prayer for revival that remembers past forgiveness and looks for a future where righteousness and peace meet. Read verses 10 to 13 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 85 is a psalm of the sons of Korah. It begins by recalling that God has restored the fortunes of Jacob, and then asks him to do it again. It may have been written after the return from Babylon, when the people were back in the land but the glory had not returned. It will be read again in Unit 14 with an emphasis on the return. Here it is a prayer from the dark side of the exile, asking God to revive his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “LORD, you were favorable to your land; you restored the fortunes of Jacob” (v. 1).
2. “You forgave the iniquity of your people; you covered all their sin” (v. 2).
3. “Restore us again, O God of our salvation, and put away your indignation toward us!” (v. 4).
4. “Will you not revive us again, that your people may rejoice in you?” (v. 6).
5. “Show us your steadfast love, O LORD, and grant us your salvation” (v. 7).
6. “Steadfast love and faithfulness meet; righteousness and peace kiss each other” (v. 10).
7. “Faithfulness springs up from the ground, and righteousness looks down from the sky” (v. 11).
8. “Righteousness will go before him and make his footsteps a way” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with memory: God has been favorable before. He forgave and covered sin and turned away from his fierce anger. This past mercy is the basis of the plea. When we do not know what to pray, we can start by recalling what God has already done.

The prayer is for revival. “Will you not revive us again, that your people may rejoice in you?” Joy in God is the goal. Revival here is not an event or a program but a renewal of the people’s delight in the LORD. It assumes that left alone, we dry out.

Then the psalmist does something striking. He says, “Let me hear what God the LORD will speak.” He stops talking and listens. And the word that comes is peace, for those who turn their hearts to him. God’s salvation is near to those who fear him, “that glory may dwell in our land.”

The center of the psalm is its beautiful picture in verses 10 and 11. Four qualities, which usually seem to pull against each other, are brought together: steadfast love and faithfulness, righteousness and peace. They meet and kiss. This is a picture of the gospel. How can God be both loving and just? How can he bring peace without compromising righteousness? In the cross, these meet. Steadfast love forgives, and faithfulness keeps the promise to punish sin. Righteousness is satisfied, and peace is made.

The psalm ends with the hope of the Lord’s appearance: “Righteousness will go before him and make his footsteps a way.” The good that will come will come from heaven and from the earth together.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 3:25-26 shows how God is both just and the justifier, where love and righteousness meet. Colossians 1:20 says that God was pleased “to reconcile to himself all things, making peace by the blood of his cross.” Romans 5:1 says that we have peace with God. John 1:14 says that the Word became flesh, full of grace and truth. Luke 2:14 announces “peace among those with whom he is pleased.”

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of the ways God has been “favorable to your land” in your life.

Pray “Will you not revive us again?” for your church and for yourself.

Sit in silence and say, “Let me hear what God the LORD will speak.” Listen for a few minutes.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to revive you.

Tell him you want steadfast love and faithfulness to meet in your life.

Thank him for his salvation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 62

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

DAY 431 · WEEK 62

Jeremiah 10:1-13:27

Idols vs. the living God; the linen loincloth

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 75 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 10:1-13:27. These chapters include a satire on idols, the covenant that was broken, Jeremiah's first complaint, and two sign-acts: a linen loincloth and wine jars. Look for how God uses ordinary objects to teach.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The setting continues in the reign of Jehoiakim. The people have been worshiping the gods of the surrounding nations, and Jeremiah mocks them. Chapters 11 and 12 reveal a personal crisis: his own village of Anathoth plots to kill him, and he asks God why the wicked prosper. Chapter 13 contains one of Jeremiah's most visual sermons.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Their idols are like scarecrows in a cucumber field, and they cannot speak" (10:5).
2. "But the LORD is the true God; he is the living God and the everlasting King" (10:10).
3. "It is he who made the earth by his power, who established the world by his wisdom" (10:12).
4. "Cursed be the man who does not hear the words of this covenant" (11:3).
5. "But I was like a gentle lamb led to the slaughter" (11:19).
6. "Why does the way of the wicked prosper? Why do all who are treacherous thrive?" (12:1).
7. "If you have raced with men on foot, and they have wearied you, how will you compete with horses?" (12:5).
8. "So I bought a loincloth… it was spoiled; it was good for nothing" (13:1-7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 10 mocks the idols with a bit of humor. They are like scarecrows. They have to be carried because they cannot walk, and they cannot do good or harm. The contrast with the LORD is sharp: “There is none like you, O LORD.” The idols are made by hands. The LORD made the earth by his power. The call is to reverent fear before the King of the nations.

Chapter 11 turns to the covenant. The people heard the covenant words at Sinai and agreed, but then broke them. Jeremiah’s own townsmen of Anathoth plot to kill him if he does not stop prophesying. Then he opens a window into his heart. In chapter 12, he does what Habakkuk did: he complains to God. “Why does the way of the wicked prosper?” He wants answers. God does not give him a neat theology. He tells him that things will get harder. If racing with men on foot has worn him out, how will he cope with horses? God is preparing him for worse. It is not comforting, but it is honest. God does not coddle his servants.

Chapter 13 shows a sign. God tells Jeremiah to buy a linen loincloth, wear it, bury it by the Euphrates, and later dig it up. It is ruined. The meaning is that Israel was meant to cling to God like a loincloth to a man’s waist, “for a people, a name, a praise, and a glory.” But they would not listen, and so they became useless. The proud will be broken. The chapter ends with a question that pierces: “Can the Ethiopian change his skin or the leopard his spots? Then also you can do good who are accustomed to do evil.” Human nature cannot reform itself. Only God can change a heart, which is why the new covenant is so needed.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 14:15 and 17:22-31 draw on this critique of idols. Jesus was led like a lamb to the slaughter (Isaiah 53:7; Acts 8:32). 1 Corinthians 8:4-6 says there is one God and one Lord, Jesus Christ. John 3:3-7 says no one can see the kingdom without being born again. Romans 7:18 says that nothing good dwells in me, that is, in my flesh. Ezekiel 36:26 promises a new heart.

STEP 6

Application

Name any “scarecrow” idol in your life that cannot speak or act. Turn from it.

If you are weary, remember God’s honesty with Jeremiah: he prepares us for what is ahead.

Ask whether you cling to God like a loincloth, close and for his glory.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God as the true, living God.

Confess where you have trusted scarecrows.

Ask him to strengthen you when you feel worn.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 62

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

DAY 432 · WEEK 62

Jeremiah 14:1-17:27

Drought and sword; the deceitful heart; the Sabbath

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 104 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 14:1-17:27. A drought and a sword fall on Judah, Jeremiah refuses to marry or celebrate, and God exposes the human heart. Read 17:5-10 slowly, which contrasts the person who trusts in man with the one who trusts in the LORD.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters begin with a drought and a series of dialogues between Jeremiah and God. God tells him three times not to intercede for the people. The prophet's personal life becomes part of the message: he is not to marry, mourn, or feast. Chapter 17 contains the famous passage on the deceitful heart, the blessed man, and a call to keep the Sabbath.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Though our iniquities testify against us, act, O LORD, for your name's sake" (14:7).
2. "Then the LORD said to me, Though Moses and Samuel stood before me, yet my heart would not turn toward this people" (15:1).
3. "Your words were found, and I ate them, and your words became to me a joy and the delight of my heart" (15:16).
4. "Why is my pain unceasing, my wound incurable?" (15:18).
5. "If you return, I will restore you, and you shall stand before me" (15:19).
6. "Cursed is the man who trusts in man and makes flesh his strength, whose heart turns away from the LORD" (17:5).
7. "Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD" (17:7).

8 “The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately sick; who can understand it?” (17:9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The drought is a covenant curse. The land is parched, the cisterns are empty, the deer abandon their fawns. The people pray, but God says they love to wander. Even if Moses and Samuel interceded, he would not turn. The time for the warning is past. It is a hard thing for a prophet who loves his people. In chapter 15, Jeremiah is deeply wounded. His one consolation was God’s word: “Your words were found, and I ate them.” He consumed the word like food, and it was joy. But his joy led to isolation: he sat alone because God’s hand was on him. His complaint about God’s apparent unreliability, “like a deceitful brook,” draws a sharp reply: “If you return, I will restore you.” Even the prophet needs to repent.

Chapter 16 forbids Jeremiah to marry, mourn, or feast. His loneliness is a sermon: life as they know it is ending. And yet, in the middle, a promise that the people will be brought back from the north, and that a new exodus will eclipse the old one.

Chapter 17 is the heart of this section. The sin of Judah is written with an iron pen, engraved on the tablet of their heart. Then a pair of contrasting trees. The person who trusts in man is like a shrub in the desert, unaware of when good comes. The one who trusts in the LORD is like a tree planted by water, unafraid in the heat, still bearing fruit in drought. And the reason: “The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately sick.” No one can fully know his own heart. But the LORD searches it. This is why we need a new heart, not just better habits.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I am the vine; you are the branches” (John 15:5), and drew on the picture of fruitfulness. Psalm 1:3 describes the same tree. Mark 7:21-23 says that out of the heart come evil thoughts. Hebrews 4:12 says the word of God discerns the thoughts and intentions of the heart. Revelation 10:9-10 shows John eating the scroll, as Jeremiah ate the words. Proverbs 4:23 says to guard your heart.

STEP 6

Application

Ask God to search your heart and show you what you cannot see (Jeremiah 17:10).

Consider where you are trusting in “flesh” this week. Redirect your trust to the LORD.

Receive the word of God as food. Spend time today with a short passage and “eat” it slowly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess that your heart is deceitful, and ask him to search it.

Ask him to lead you in the way everlasting.

Thank him that he tests the mind.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 62

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

DAY 433 · WEEK 62

Jeremiah 18:1-20:18

The potter's house; the broken flask; Jeremiah beaten

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 18:1-20:18. Jeremiah visits a potter's house, smashes a clay jar in front of the elders, and is beaten and put in stocks. Then he writes one of the darkest prayers in the Bible. Read the potter scene first, then chapter 20.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Two sign-acts mark these chapters: the potter at his wheel (chapter 18) and the shattered flask in the Valley of Hinnom (chapter 19). The second one costs him dearly. The priest Pashhur, chief officer of the temple, has Jeremiah beaten and put in the stocks. When he is released, Jeremiah gives his harshest complaint to God, and the book shows us how a faithful prophet feels when faithfulness seems to ruin his life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, like the clay in the potter's hand, so are you in my hand, O house of Israel" (18:6).
2. "If that nation concerning which I have spoken turns from its evil, I will relent of the disaster that I intended to do to it" (18:8).
3. "But they say, That is in vain! We will follow our own plans" (18:12).
4. "So you shall break the flask in the sight of the men who go with you" (19:10).
5. "Thus will I break this people and this city, as one breaks a potter's vessel" (19:11).
6. "Then Pashhur… struck Jeremiah the prophet, and put him in the stocks" (20:2).
7. "O LORD, you have deceived me, and I was deceived; you are stronger than I, and you have prevailed" (20:7).

8 “If I say, I will not mention him, or speak any more in his name, there is in my heart as it were a burning fire shut up in my bones, and I am weary with holding it in, and I cannot” (20:9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

At the potter’s house, Jeremiah watches a vessel spoil in the potter’s hands, and the potter reshapes it into another. God’s lesson is about sovereignty and responsiveness. The potter has the right to shape the clay. But the passage also teaches that God responds to repentance. If a nation under judgment turns, he will relent. If a nation that was promised blessing turns to evil, he will withdraw it. The warnings and promises of the prophets are not fixed in stone but are addressed to human response. And yet the people reply, “We will follow our own plans.”

In chapter 19, Jeremiah is told to buy a finished clay jar and take the elders to the Valley of Hinnom, where children had been burned to Baal, and smash it. A clay pot that has been fired cannot be remade. The first sign-act showed that a repentant clay could be reshaped. The second shows that stubborn clay will be broken beyond repair. The message: God has been patient, but there is a point at which the vessel is hardened.

The punishment comes at once. Pashhur strikes him and puts him in the stocks overnight. Jeremiah’s reply is a blazing prophecy of exile. Then he is alone with God, and he prays one of the most honest prayers in Scripture. “You have deceived me.” He feels that God has trapped him. The word of the LORD has become a reproach and derision. Yet he cannot quit: “There is in my heart as it were a burning fire shut up in my bones.” He cannot stop speaking.

He ends with trust, “the LORD is with me as a dread warrior,” and then with despair, “Cursed be the day on which I was born.” Both are in one chapter. The Bible does not tidy faith. It shows a servant of God who is faithful and in agony.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 9:20-21 draws on the potter and clay. Isaiah 64:8 says, “You are the potter; we are the clay.” Matthew 27:7-10 connects the potter’s field to the death of Judas, with a quotation attributed to Jeremiah. Paul speaks of treasure in jars of clay (2 Corinthians 4:7). Acts 5:40-41 shows the apostles rejoicing when beaten. Luke 24:32 describes hearts burning within as Jesus opened the Scriptures.

STEP 6

Application

Place one area of your life in the potter's hands, and ask him to reshape it.

If you are discouraged in serving God, pray honestly like Jeremiah. God can handle it.

Ask for the "burning fire" of the word in your heart, and for courage to share it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you are clay and he is the potter, and let him reshape you.
- Ask him to help you when serving him hurts.
- Thank him for his faithfulness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 62

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

DAY 434 · WEEK 62

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Jeremiah 17:7-8 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."

JEREMIAH 17:7-8

REST

Meditation

Jeremiah wrote these words in a land of drought, to a people who were trusting in everything but God. It is a promise that holds in hard seasons.

"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD." The word "blessed" means deeply happy, in a good place. The Bible links this blessing not to circumstances but to trust. And the trust is placed in a person: "whose trust is the LORD." He himself is the trust. It is not trust in a technique, a doctrine as such, or a strategy for success. It is a relationship with a person.

"He is like a tree planted by water." The picture is of a tree whose roots go to the stream. In a dry country, the tree by the water has a source that does not depend on rainfall. The roots do the hidden work, "sending out" toward the water. So much of the Christian life is hidden roots: time in prayer, reading Scripture, quiet obedience, worship.

“Does not fear when heat comes.” Notice that heat does come. The blessed person is not spared the heat. But they do not fear it, because the roots are in the stream. The next verse adds, “Its leaves remain green, and is not anxious in the year of drought, for it does not cease to bear fruit.” In the drought it keeps bearing fruit.

Contrast the previous verses: the person who trusts in man is a shrub in the desert. The difference is not in the climate but in the source. Say this verse and ask where your roots are going this week.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you stood in the temple gate with Jeremiah and heard the sermon that said a building cannot save you. You read the great questions: “Is there no balm in Gilead?” and the invitation to boast only in knowing the LORD. You prayed Psalms 79 and 85, a lament over the ruined city and a prayer for revival in which steadfast love and faithfulness meet. You read Jeremiah’s mockery of idols, his own struggle when the wicked prosper, and the ruined loincloth. You read the deceitful heart and the two trees. You watched the potter, the shattered jar, and Jeremiah in the stocks, burning with the word he could not hold in. The week taught that God’s patience has limits, that religion without obedience is empty, and that the one who trusts in the LORD is like a tree by the stream.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jeremiah warned people not to trust in the temple as a charm. What “temple of the LORD” slogan might you be leaning on instead of obedience?

Jeremiah’s prayers are honest, even angry. What do you need to bring honestly to God that you have been holding back?

The blessed man in Jeremiah 17 is like a tree planted by water. What are the “roots” you are sending out each week, and where might they be shallow?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you send roots deep into him.

Tell him how you want to trust him in heat and drought.

Thank Jesus in whom you are blessed.

DAY 435 · WEEK 63

Psalm 102

A prayer of the afflicted

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 102. It is headed “A prayer of one afflicted, when he is faint and pours out his complaint before the LORD.” Notice how the psalm moves from personal misery to the eternal reign of God, and how the New Testament quotes the end.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 102 is one of the seven penitential psalms in church tradition. It has no named author. It is the cry of an individual who feels his life vanishing like smoke, and at the same time a prayer for Zion’s restoration, which fits the exile. It sets private suffering inside the story of God’s people and the story of creation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Hear my prayer, O LORD; let my cry come to you!” (v. 1).
2. “For my days pass away like smoke, and my bones burn like a furnace” (v. 3).
3. “I am like a lonely sparrow on the housetop” (v. 7).
4. “For I eat ashes like bread, and mingle tears with my drink” (vv. 9).
5. “My days are like an evening shadow; I wither away like grass” (v. 11).
6. “But you, O LORD, are enthroned forever; you are remembered throughout all generations” (v. 12).
7. “You will arise and have pity on Zion; it is the time to favor her” (v. 13).
8. “Of old you laid the foundation of the earth… They will perish, but you will remain… but you are the same, and your years have no end” (vv. 25-27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a rush of need: hear me, do not hide your face, answer me speedily. The description that follows is vivid and bodily. His days vanish like smoke. His bones burn. His heart is struck down like grass. He forgets to eat. He is wasted by groaning. He is like a pelican in the wilderness or an owl among ruins, a sleepless bird alone on a roof. And he feels that God has lifted him up only to throw him down. Few passages in the Bible describe depression and isolation so plainly.

The turning point is a single word at verse 12: “But you, O LORD.” Against all that is passing and fading, the psalmist sets the One who is enthroned forever. The shadow of his life lengthens, but God’s name endures to all generations. The change of view then opens his prayer outward. He asks that God will have pity on Zion. “The nations will fear the name of the LORD,” and a people yet to be created will praise him.

The psalm ends with creation itself. The heavens and earth will wear out like a garment, but God is the same. This is the final consolation for the dying and discouraged: the one in whom we trust does not change. “The children of your servants shall dwell secure.” The prayer of one man’s faintness is carried by the unchanging God.

Hebrews 1:10-12 quotes verses 25 to 27 and applies them to the Son. The one who laid the foundation of the earth and who will remain when it perishes is Jesus. So the faint and afflicted worshiper in the psalm is praying to Christ, whose years have no end.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 1:10-12 attributes Psalm 102:25-27 to the Son, showing his eternal deity. Hebrews 13:8 says, “Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever.” 2 Corinthians 4:16-18 speaks of the outer self wasting away while the inner self is renewed. Romans 8:18 says the sufferings of this present time are not worth comparing with the glory to be revealed. Malachi 3:6 says, “I the LORD do not change.”

STEP 6

Application

If you are weary or lonely, pray the first eleven verses honestly, then pray verse 12 as a turning point.

Name something that is fading in your life, and remember who remains.

Pray for the church in the places where it seems to be in ruins.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry out to God from your affliction.
- Tell him that he is enthroned forever.
- Ask him to arise and have pity.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 63

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

DAY 436 · WEEK 63

Psalm 103

Bless the LORD, O my soul, steadfast love as high as heaven

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 103. After a psalm of exhaustion, here is a psalm of praise, one of the most loved in the whole Psalter. You may have read it before. Read it slowly, and let every phrase about forgiveness sink in.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 103 is a psalm of David. It is an individual's call to himself to bless the LORD, which widens out to include all God's people and all creation. After Jeremiah's relentless warnings and Psalm 102's affliction, it stands as a declaration of what the God of the exile is really like. It will appear again later in the plan. Today read it as the answer to what Jeremiah and the psalmists have been asking: what is God like when we have failed?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Bless the LORD, O my soul, and all that is within me, bless his holy name!" (v. 1).
2. "Forget not all his benefits" (v. 2).
3. "Who forgives all your iniquity, who heals all your diseases" (v. 3).
4. "The LORD works righteousness and justice for all who are oppressed" (v. 6).
5. "The LORD is merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love" (v. 8).
6. "He does not deal with us according to our sins, nor repay us according to our iniquities" (v. 10).
7. "As far as the east is from the west, so far does he remove our transgressions from us" (v. 12).

8 “As a father shows compassion to his children, so the LORD shows compassion to those who fear him. For he knows our frame; he remembers that we are dust” (vv. 13-14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David begins by speaking to his own soul. He commands himself to bless the LORD, and to remember. “Forget not all his benefits.” The psalm’s work is remembering, since we are forgetful. Then he lists them: forgiveness, healing, redemption from the pit, a crown of steadfast love, and satisfaction with good, so that your youth is renewed like the eagle’s. Forgiveness is the first item, and it is the benefit that makes the rest possible.

In verses 6 to 8, David recalls the way God made himself known to Moses: merciful and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in steadfast love. This is the self-description from Exodus 34:6, which Jonah quoted, and which echoes through the Bible. And the psalm unpacks it. God does not keep his anger forever. He does not deal with us according to our sins. The heavens are high above the earth, but his steadfast love is greater than that. The east is far from the west, and that is how far he has removed our transgressions.

Here is the point for the unit. This psalm is true even in exile. The exile was real judgment, and it was a sign that God deals with sin. But it was not the whole story. He did not repay them according to their iniquities. He kept a remnant. He promised to bring them back.

Verses 13 to 14 give the reason: God is like a father who knows his children. “He knows our frame; he remembers that we are dust.” God is not surprised by our weakness. He is gentle with it. The psalm ends by calling the angels, the mighty ones, and all creation to bless the LORD, and then returns to the beginning: “Bless the LORD, O my soul.”

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 1:7 says that in Christ we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses. Hebrews 8:12 and 10:17 promise that God will remember our sins no more. Romans 8:15 says that we cry, “Abba! Father!” Luke 15:20 shows the father who ran to meet his son. 1 John 1:9 promises forgiveness and cleansing. Micah 7:18-19 says he casts all our sins into the depths of the sea.

STEP 6

Application

Write down five of God’s benefits to you, and thank him for each.

Preach to your own soul: say aloud “Bless the LORD, O my soul” when you feel low.

Rest in the truth that God remembers that you are dust. Bring your weakness to him without fear.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bless the LORD with all that is within you.

Name a benefit of his that you do not want to forget.

Thank him for his love as high as the heavens.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 63

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

DAY 437 · WEEK 63

Jeremiah 21:1-24:10

Kings condemned; the good and bad figs; the 70 years

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 21:1-24:10. Jeremiah speaks to the last kings of Judah, promises a righteous Branch, condemns the false shepherds, and sees two baskets of figs. Read 23:1-8 and chapter 24 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters mostly date to the reign of Zedekiah, the last king, around 590 BC, while Babylon was closing in. The king sends messengers to Jeremiah asking for a miracle, and the prophet answers that God himself is fighting against Jerusalem. Then he describes the failure of the kings of Judah. In the midst of the gloom come some of the book's most important promises of a coming king and a restored remnant.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, I set before you the way of life and the way of death" (21:8).
2. "Woe to him who builds his house by unrighteousness… who makes his neighbor serve him for nothing" (22:13).
3. "Did not your father eat and drink and do justice and righteousness? … He judged the cause of the poor and needy; then it was well. Is not this to know me?" (22:15-16).
4. "Woe to the shepherds who destroy and scatter the sheep of my pasture!" (23:1).
5. "Behold, the days are coming, declares the LORD, when I will raise up for David a righteous Branch" (23:5).
6. "And this is the name by which he will be called: The LORD is our righteousness" (23:6).
7. "Am I a God at hand, declares the LORD, and not a God far away?" (23:23).

8 “Like these good figs, so I will regard as good the exiles from Judah” (24:5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The king asks for a miracle, as Hezekiah once received. But this time there is no deliverance. God says, “I myself will fight against you.” The choice for the people is stark: go out and surrender to Babylon and live, or stay and die. It sounds like treason, and Jeremiah is treated that way. It was actually a call to humble submission to God’s chastening.

Chapters 22 and 23 deal with the kings. Shallum, Jehoiakim, and Jehoiachin are in turn condemned. Jehoiakim built a luxurious palace with forced labor. God contrasts him with his father Josiah, who did justice and righteousness and judged the cause of the poor and needy. The key line: “Is not this to know me?” To know God is to care for the vulnerable. Knowledge of God is shown in justice.

Then the shepherds. God accuses the leaders of scattering his flock. But he will gather the remnant himself and give them shepherds who will feed them. And then the promise: “I will raise up for David a righteous Branch.” This king will reign wisely and do justice. His name is “The LORD is our righteousness.” Zedekiah means “The LORD is my righteousness,” but the last king of Judah did not live up to his name. The Branch will.

The chapter then attacks the false prophets who speak visions of their own minds and say, “It shall be well with you.” They have not stood in the council of the LORD. God’s word is like fire and like a hammer.

Chapter 24 gives a vision of two baskets of figs: good figs and bad. The surprise is who is who. The good figs are the exiles in Babylon, and the bad figs are those left in Jerusalem. God says the exiles are his remnant: “I will build them up, and not tear down.” “I will give them a heart to know that I am the LORD.” What looks like judgment is the path to new life.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 1:21 gives the name Jesus: he will save his people. 1 Corinthians 1:30 says Christ became for us righteousness. Ezekiel 34 develops the shepherd image, and Jesus fulfills it in John 10:11. Matthew 7:15-20 warns about false prophets who are known by their fruit. Philippians 2:12-13 says God works in us to will and to do his good pleasure. Romans 8:28 says that God works all things for good.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your knowledge of God is shown in how you treat the poor and needy, as Jeremiah says it should be.

Pray for church leaders to be faithful shepherds, and for your own shepherding of those in your care.

Consider a season in your life that seemed like exile. How did God use it to give you a heart to know him?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is our righteousness.

Thank him for the righteous Branch of David.

Ask him to give his people shepherds after his own heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 63

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

DAY 438 · WEEK 63

Jeremiah 25:1-27:22

The cup of wrath; false prophets; the yoke of Babylon

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 25:1-27:22. Jeremiah announces seventy years of captivity, passes a cup of wrath to the nations, and nearly loses his life for the temple sermon. Then he wears a wooden yoke. Look for what God says about Nebuchadnezzar.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 25 dates to 605 BC, the fourth year of Jehoiakim, the year of the Battle of Carchemish when Babylon became the dominant power and Nebuchadnezzar took the first exiles, including Daniel. Chapter 26 records the trial that followed the temple sermon. Chapter 27 jumps to the reign of Zedekiah, with Jeremiah wearing a yoke of straps and bars, a living picture of submission to Babylon.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “For twenty-three years… the word of the LORD has come to me, and I have spoken persistently to you, but you have not listened” (25:3).
2. “Behold, I will send for all the tribes of the north… and for Nebuchadnezzar the king of Babylon, my servant” (25:9).
3. “This whole land shall become a ruin and a waste, and these nations shall serve the king of Babylon seventy years” (25:11).
4. “Take from my hand this cup of the wine of wrath” (25:15).
5. “You will surely die! … This man deserves the sentence of death” (26:8, 11).
6. “Behold, I am in your hands. Do with me as seems good and right to you. Only know for certain that if you put me to death, you will bring innocent blood upon yourselves”

(26:14-15).

7. "Make yourself straps and yoke bars, and put them on your neck" (27:2).

8. "But any nation that will bring its neck under the yoke of the king of Babylon and serve him, I will leave on its own land" (27:11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 25 is the summary of Jeremiah's ministry so far. For twenty-three years he spoke and the people did not listen. Now God declares the sentence: seventy years of Babylonian rule. Remarkably, he calls Nebuchadnezzar "my servant." The pagan king is a tool in God's hand, used for his purposes. After the seventy years, Babylon too will be judged. Daniel would later read this passage in prayer (Daniel 9:2).

God then gives Jeremiah a cup of the wine of his wrath to pass to all the nations. The picture is of a drunken stagger. No one is exempt, from Jerusalem to Egypt to Sheshach, a code word for Babylon. Judgment begins with God's own people ("the city that is called by my name") and extends to everyone.

Chapter 26 shows what it costs Jeremiah to preach this. The priests and prophets demand his death. But the officials and some elders defend him, pointing to Micah, who prophesied judgment in Hezekiah's day and was not killed, because the king repented. Jeremiah's calm defense is moving. He is in their hands, but he warns them not to shed innocent blood. The word of God does not change to suit the listener.

Chapter 27 is the yoke. He wears it publicly and sends models to the neighboring kings. His message: serve Babylon, and live. False prophets say that the vessels of the temple will soon come back. Jeremiah says that they will go. It is the harder message because it is true. Faith here means accepting what God says even when popular prophets say otherwise.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 9:2 says that Daniel understood from the books the number of years that must pass for the desolation of Jerusalem, "seventy years." Isaiah 51:17 and Revelation 14:10 use the cup of wrath imagery. Jesus prayed in Gethsemane, "Let this cup pass from me" (Matthew 26:39), and drank it for us. Romans 13:1 says that governing authorities are instituted by God. Acts 5:29 says we must obey God rather than men.

STEP 6

Application

Consider whether you resist a hard message because it is not what you want to hear. Ask God for ears to hear.

Remember that God can use a Nebuchadnezzar. Look for how he is using something you did not choose.

Pray for courage like Jeremiah's before an angry crowd.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you ears to hear his word even when it is hard.
- Thank Jesus for drinking the cup of wrath for you.
- Pray for nations and leaders.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 63

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

DAY 439 · WEEK 63

Jeremiah 28:1-29:32

Hananiah; the letter to the exiles, seek the city's peace

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 28:1-29:32. A false prophet breaks Jeremiah's yoke, and Jeremiah writes a letter to the exiles. Pay close attention to 29:4-14. This is one of the most important passages in the Bible on how to live in a foreign place.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In 594 BC, a few years after the first exile, a prophet named Hananiah announced in the temple that Babylon's power would be broken in two years. Jeremiah answered, and then Hananiah died. Meanwhile, the exiles in Babylon were being told by false prophets that their stay would be short. Jeremiah sent them a letter with a different message: settle in, because you will be there for seventy years.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Thus says the LORD of hosts… I have broken the yoke of the king of Babylon" (28:2).
2. "Amen! May the LORD do so" (28:6).
3. "The prophet who prophesies peace, when the word of that prophet comes to pass, then it will be known that the LORD has truly sent the prophet" (28:9).
4. "You have broken wooden bars, but you have made in their place bars of iron" (28:13).
5. "Build houses and live in them; plant gardens and eat their produce. Take wives and have sons and daughters" (29:5-6).
6. "But seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the LORD on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare" (29:7).

7. “For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope” (29:11).

8. “You will seek me and find me, when you seek me with all your heart” (29:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Hananiah’s prophecy was exactly what the people wanted to hear. Jeremiah’s first response is irony: “Amen! May the LORD do so.” He would love for the prophecy to be true. But he reminds Hananiah that true prophets have always spoken of war, famine, and plague, and a message of peace must be proved by its fulfillment. Hananiah breaks the wooden yoke from Jeremiah’s neck, and God replaces it with one of iron. Hananiah dies within two months. A message that contradicts God’s word is not only wrong but dangerous.

Chapter 29 is the exiles’ letter. It must have been a surprise. They were hoping to go home soon. Instead, Jeremiah says to settle: build houses, plant gardens, marry, and have children. Do not shrink. Even more surprising: “Seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the LORD on its behalf.” Pray for Babylon! Because in its welfare is your welfare. The people of God are called to be faithful and good neighbors in a place that is not their home.

Then comes the famous promise, 29:11, so often quoted alone. Read in context, it is not a promise of quick comfort. It was given to people who would spend seventy years in exile. The plans are for welfare and a future, but the timeline is long. The next verses give the way: call on me, pray, seek me with all your heart, and I will be found.

This is an important teaching for all Christians, since we are exiles and sojourners. We are not to withdraw, and we are not to be absorbed. We are to build, plant, pray, and wait for the promised return.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Peter 2:11-17 calls believers “sojourners and exiles” who are to honor everyone and live good lives among the Gentiles. 1 Timothy 2:1-2 urges prayer for kings and all in authority. Matthew 7:15-23 warns against false prophets. Hebrews 11:13-16 says that the faithful were strangers and exiles on the earth, seeking a better country. John 17:15-18 shows Jesus praying that his disciples be kept in the world, not removed from it.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for your city and its leaders by name this week, including those you disagree with.

Think about how you can build and plant where you are rather than waiting for something better.

Read Jeremiah 29:11 with 29:10 and 29:13, and trust that God's plans are long and good.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for his plans for welfare and a future and hope.
- Ask him to teach you to seek the welfare of where you live.
- Ask him for patience in the waiting.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 63

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

DAY 440 · WEEK 63

Psalm 106

We have sinned like our fathers

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 106. It is a long review of Israel's history of rebellion, from the Red Sea to the exile, told as a confession. You have seen this theme in earlier units. This time read it as a prayer from within the exile.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 106 is a companion to Psalm 105, which told the story of God's faithfulness. This psalm tells the story of the people's unfaithfulness. It ends with a prayer from the exile, "Save us, O LORD our God, and gather us from among the nations." It closes Book 4 of the Psalter with a doxology. It is a good psalm to pray with Jeremiah, because it confesses the very sin he accuses.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever!" (v. 1).
2. "Both we and our fathers have sinned; we have committed iniquity; we have done wickedly" (v. 6).
3. "Yet he saved them for his name's sake, that he might make known his mighty power" (v. 8).
4. "But they soon forgot his works; they did not wait for his counsel" (v. 13).
5. "They exchanged the glory of God for the image of an ox that eats grass" (v. 20).
6. "Therefore he said he would destroy them, had not Moses, his chosen one, stood in the breach before him" (v. 23).

7. “They served their idols, which became a snare to them. They sacrificed their sons and their daughters to the demons” (vv. 36-37).

8. “Save us, O LORD our God, and gather us from among the nations, that we may give thanks to your holy name and glory in your praise” (v. 47).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins as praise but quickly becomes confession. “Both we and our fathers have sinned.” The writer does not blame the fathers or hide behind history. He includes himself. And he goes through the story: at the Red Sea, the people forgot the miracles. In the wilderness, they craved meat and tested God. At Sinai, they made a golden calf. At the border of Canaan, they refused to enter. At Baal-peor, they joined in the worship of Baal. At Meribah, they provoked Moses. In the land, they mingled with the nations, worshiped their idols, and even sacrificed their children.

The pattern is repeated, and so is God’s response. Again and again, he saves “for his name’s sake.” He hears their cry. He remembers his covenant and relents “according to the abundance of his steadfast love.” Even when he disciplines, he shows compassion. The turning point in several stories is a mediator: Moses stood in the breach, and Phinehas stood up and intervened.

In the context of the exile, the psalm is the historical confession of a generation that realizes where it stands. The nation did not suddenly fall. It was the end of a long habit. And yet the closing prayer is a hopeful one: “Save us, O LORD our God, and gather us from among the nations.” The psalmist asks for what God has always done: save for his name’s sake.

The psalm ends with a doxology: “Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, from everlasting to everlasting! And let all the people say, Amen!” The history of failure does not silence praise.

STEP 5

Connection

Stephen’s speech in Acts 7 retells the same history, showing the persistent resistance to the Holy Spirit. 1 Corinthians 10:1-12 uses the wilderness stories as warnings: “These things happened to them as an example.” Romans 1:23 echoes verse 20: exchanging the glory of God for images. Hebrews 7:25 says that Jesus always lives to make intercession, the greater Moses who stands in the breach.

STEP 6

Application

Practice the kind of confession this psalm models: name specific sins, and include yourself in the patterns of your family, church, and culture.

Thank God for the mediators who have stood in the breach for you, and for Christ above all.

Pray the last verse for scattered believers around the world.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess your own forgetting of God's works.
- Thank him for saving you for his name's sake.
- Thank him for the greater Mediator who stands in the breach.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 63

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

DAY 441 · WEEK 63

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Jeremiah 29:11 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."

JEREMIAH 29:11

REST

Meditation

This is one of the most quoted verses in the Bible, and it is often quoted out of context. To hear it as Jeremiah's first readers did, remember who it was written to.

It was written to exiles, people who had lost their city, their temple, and their king. They were in a foreign land with no sign of returning. False prophets were telling them it would be over soon. Then Jeremiah's letter arrived, and it said that they would be there for seventy years. After that, this promise: "For I know the plans I have for you."

The first thing it says is that God has plans. The exile was not an accident. It was part of what he was doing. The second is that he knows them. We often do not know the plans, and we do not need to, because he knows them. The third is that they are "plans for welfare," shalom, wholeness, "and not for evil." The word for evil is the word for calamity. The exile looked like calamity, but God's purpose was good.

Finally, “to give you a future and a hope.” The future is real. The hope is not a wish but an expectation based on God’s word. In the same chapter, God says he will bring them back. The promise does not remove the seventy years. It gives them meaning.

This verse does not promise an easy life. It promises that the one who holds your future is good. For Christians, the ultimate fulfillment is in Christ, in whom all of God’s promises are “Yes.” Say this verse when you do not know what comes next.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed Jeremiah through the rest of his early ministry. You read the king’s last warnings and the promise of a righteous Branch whose name is “The LORD is our righteousness.” You saw the vision of two baskets of figs, in which the exiles were the good figs. You read about the cup of wrath, the seventy years, the yoke of Babylon, and the false prophet Hananiah. Then you read the letter to the exiles, which told them to build, plant, and seek the welfare of the city. You prayed Psalms 102 and 103, the cry of the afflicted and the praise of the God who removes our sins as far as the east is from the west, and Psalm 106, a history of rebellion and mercy. The week taught that God is sovereign over exile, that false hope is dangerous, and that his plans for his people are for welfare and a future.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jeremiah told the exiles to seek the welfare of Babylon. How can you seek the good of the place where God has put you this week?

Psalm 103 says God removes our transgressions as far as the east is from the west. Where do you still carry guilt that Christ has already carried?

The false prophets promised quick relief, and Jeremiah promised a long road with a sure hope. Which do you tend to want, and how does Jeremiah 29:11 speak to that?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his plans for your welfare and a future and a hope.

Ask him to teach you to seek the good of the place he has put you.

Rest in his faithfulness this Sabbath.

DAY 442 · WEEK 64

Psalm 107:1-22

He redeems from every adversity

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 107:1-22. It begins Book 5 of the Psalter, and it is a song for the redeemed, those gathered from the lands. Notice the refrain that repeats in each scene.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 107 opens the last book of the Psalms. It has no author but clearly looks back on the return from exile: "those he redeemed from trouble and gathered in from the lands." The psalm tells four stories of people in distress: wanderers, prisoners, the sick, and sailors. The first three are in today's reading. The psalm appears several times in this plan, with different parts. Here read it as a thanksgiving song for those who know what it is to be rescued.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever!" (v. 1).
2. "Let the redeemed of the LORD say so, whom he has redeemed from trouble and gathered in from the lands" (vv. 2-3).
3. "Some wandered in desert wastes... hungry and thirsty, their soul fainted within them" (vv. 4-5).
4. "Then they cried to the LORD in their trouble, and he delivered them from their distress" (v. 6).
5. "Some sat in darkness and in the shadow of death, prisoners in affliction and in irons" (v. 10).

6. “He brought them out of darkness and the shadow of death, and burst their bonds apart” (v. 14).
7. “Some were fools through their sinful ways… they drew near to the gates of death” (vv. 17-18).
8. “He sent out his word and healed them, and delivered them from their destruction” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm follows a pattern in each of its stories. First, people are in trouble: lost, imprisoned, sick, or at sea. Second, they cry to the LORD in their trouble. Third, he delivers them. And fourth, a refrain: “Let them thank the LORD for his steadfast love, for his wondrous works to the children of men.” The repetition teaches us to see all rescue as grace.

The first group are wanderers. They are lost in the desert, hungry, with no city to dwell in. The exiles, scattered across Babylon, would have recognized themselves. God leads them by a straight way to a city to live in. The second are prisoners. They sit in darkness because they rebelled against the words of God. Their bondage is a result of sin. Yet when they cry, he breaks the doors of bronze and cuts the bars of iron. The third are the sick, “fools through their sinful ways,” who suffer affliction because of their iniquities. And again, when they cry, “he sent out his word and healed them.”

Notice the phrase, “He sent out his word and healed them.” The word of God is the instrument of healing. It reminds us of creation, where God spoke, and of the gospel, where Jesus speaks and the sick are healed.

Who are the redeemed? The psalm says: everyone who has been in distress and cried out. Not only Israel, but “the children of men.” Redemption in the Bible is not for the strong or the clean, but for those who cry.

The psalm ends this part with an invitation to offer thank offerings and “tell of his deeds in songs of joy.” Gratitude is the right response to rescue.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 8:5-13 shows Jesus healing the centurion’s servant with a word, as in verse 20. Luke 4:18 says Jesus came to proclaim liberty to the captives. Colossians 1:13 says God “has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son.” Ephesians 2:1-5 speaks of being dead in trespasses and made alive. Acts 16:25-26 shows prison doors opened as Paul and Silas prayed.

STEP 6

Application

Think about which of the four pictures fits your story: wanderer, prisoner, sick, or sailor. Thank God for his rescue.

Say the refrain aloud: “Let them thank the LORD for his steadfast love.”

Tell someone a story of God’s rescue in your life this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God for a way he has redeemed you from adversity.
- Thank him that his steadfast love endures forever.
- Tell him whom you want to share this thanks with.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 64

“I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you.”

JEREMIAH 31:3

DAY 443 · WEEK 64

Jeremiah 30:1-31:40

The Book of Consolation, the New Covenant promise

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 30:1-31:40. This is the Book of Consolation, the center of Jeremiah and one of the most important passages in the Old Testament. Read chapter 31 slowly, especially verses 31 to 34. Today's reading contains the New Covenant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After many chapters of judgment, God tells Jeremiah to write in a book all the words he has spoken, and the tone turns to comfort. These chapters were probably written around 587 BC, as Jerusalem was under siege. They promise restoration, a return from exile, and above all, a new covenant. They are the hinge on which the whole unit turns, and the New Testament quotes them more than any other part of Jeremiah.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Alas! That day is so great there is none like it; it is a time of distress for Jacob; yet he shall be saved out of it" (30:7).
2. "They shall serve the LORD their God and David their king, whom I will raise up for them" (30:9).
3. "For I will restore health to you, and your wounds I will heal, declares the LORD" (30:17).
4. "I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you" (31:3).
5. "A voice is heard in Ramah, lamentation and bitter weeping. Rachel is weeping for her children" (31:15).

6. “Behold, the days are coming, declares the LORD, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah” (31:31).

7. “I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people” (31:33).

8. “For I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more” (31:34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 30 begins with distress, “a time of trouble for Jacob,” but quickly turns to salvation. God will break the yoke from their neck. They will serve the LORD and a king from David’s line. “For I will restore health to you.” The wound is incurable, but God says he will heal it. The people thought their situation was hopeless. God says that he is the one who made the wound, and he is the one who will heal it.

Chapter 31 opens with a love poem. “I have loved you with an everlasting love.” Before there was a covenant, there was love. “Therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you.” The exile has not ended his love. He promises to build them up again, with joy and dancing. The weeping at Ramah, where the exiles gathered on their way to Babylon, will turn to hope: “There is hope for your future.” Matthew later applies this verse to the weeping of Bethlehem’s mothers.

Then, in verses 31 to 34, the climax. A new covenant. It will not be like the covenant made at Sinai, which the people broke. This time, God himself will write the law on their hearts. The old covenant was written on stone and often kept externally. The new will be internal. There will be four promises: a new heart (“I will write it on their hearts”), a new relationship (“I will be their God, and they shall be my people”), a new knowledge (“they shall all know me, from the least of them to the greatest”), and a new forgiveness (“I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more”).

The closing verses guarantee it. As certain as the sun, moon, and stars, God will not cast off Israel. The new covenant is as secure as creation. It is the heart of the gospel, and it is the memory verse of this unit.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said at the Last Supper, “This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood” (Luke 22:20). Hebrews 8:6-13 and 10:15-18 quote this passage in full, saying that Christ is the mediator of the new covenant. 2 Corinthians 3:3-6 says believers are “a letter from Christ… written not with ink but with the Spirit.” Matthew 2:17-18 quotes Jeremiah 31:15. Romans 11:26-27 speaks of the covenant with Israel.

STEP 6

Application

Take Jeremiah 31:33 with you, and ask what it means that God writes rather than demands.

Take the cup at the Lord's Supper, and see in it the fulfillment of verse 31.

Ask God to write his law on your heart, so that obedience becomes your desire.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he has loved you with an everlasting love.
- Thank him for the new covenant sealed in Jesus' blood.
- Ask him to write his law on your heart so that obedience becomes your desire.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 64

"I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you."

JEREMIAH 31:3

DAY 444 · WEEK 64

Jeremiah 32:1-33:26

Jeremiah buys a field; the Branch of David

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 32:1-33:26. While Babylon is besieging the city, God tells Jeremiah to buy a field. Read it as an act of faith. Then read the promise of the Branch and the covenant with David and the Levites.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is 587 BC, the tenth year of Zedekiah. Jerusalem is under siege, and Jeremiah is imprisoned in the court of the guard for predicting its fall. God tells him that his cousin will come and offer to sell him the family field at Anathoth, which is now in enemy territory. He buys it. The scene is among the most striking acts of faith in Scripture.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Buy my field that is at Anathoth, for you have the right of redemption by purchase” (32:7).
2. “I signed the deed, sealed it, got witnesses, and weighed the money on scales” (32:10).
3. “Ah, Lord GOD! It is you who have made the heavens and the earth by your great power… Nothing is too hard for you” (32:17).
4. “Behold, I am the LORD, the God of all flesh. Is anything too hard for me?” (32:27).
5. “I will make with them an everlasting covenant, that I will not turn away from doing good to them” (32:40).
6. “Fields shall be bought in this land of which you are saying, It is a desolation” (32:43).
7. “Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known” (33:3).

8 “In those days and at that time I will cause a righteous Branch to spring up for David” (33:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jeremiah’s act is a visible sermon. The Babylonian army is at the gate. Anyone who buys land in the country is wasting money. But God says: buy it. The deed is signed, sealed, witnessed, and placed in a clay jar to last a long time. The meaning: “Houses and fields and vineyards shall again be bought in this land.” Jeremiah invests in a future he cannot see. His purchase is a pledge of God’s promise.

Afterward, Jeremiah prays, and he is honest about his confusion. “Behold, the siege mounds have come up to the city… and the city is given into the hands of the Chaldeans. What you spoke has come to pass, and behold, you see it. Yet you, O Lord GOD, have said to me, Buy the field.” How can both be true? God answers with a question: “Is anything too hard for me?” He confirms the judgment, but promises restoration. “I will gather them from all the countries.” He will give them one heart and one way, “that they may fear me forever.” And again the promise of the everlasting covenant, “that I will not turn away from doing good to them.”

Chapter 33 continues the theme from a prison. God says, “Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things.” It is a promise to those who pray in impossible situations. The city will be healed and cleansed. The sounds of joy and gladness will return, “the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride,” and of those who bring thank offerings.

The center is the promise of the Branch: “I will cause a righteous Branch to spring up for David.” The covenant with David will not fail. As sure as day and night, God’s promises stand. Even in the siege, Jeremiah’s hope is not in the army but in the word of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 1:37 says, “For nothing will be impossible with God,” echoing Jeremiah 32:17 and 27. Mark 10:27 says that all things are possible with God. Hebrews 11:1 says faith is the assurance of things hoped for. Jeremiah’s purchase of the field fits Ephesians 1:13-14, where the Spirit is the guarantee of our inheritance. Romans 4:17-21 describes Abraham believing against hope. Psalm 50:15 invites us to call on God in the day of trouble.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where God may be asking you to act in faith toward a future you cannot yet see.

Memorize Jeremiah 33:3 and pray it in a situation that seems impossible.

Pray the question, “Is anything too hard for the LORD?” for a specific need.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God that nothing is too hard for him, and name the thing you have been afraid to ask.

Ask him to teach you to “buy fields” in faith, trusting his promises.

Thank him for the Branch of David.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 64

“I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you.”

JEREMIAH 31:3

DAY 445 · WEEK 64

Jeremiah 34:1-36:32

Zedekiah; the Rechabites; Baruch's scroll burned

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 84 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 34:1-36:32. The king breaks a covenant to free slaves. A family called the Rechabites keeps its vow. And King Jehoiakim burns Jeremiah's scroll in a fire. Read these three stories as a contrast between faithful and unfaithful responses to God's word.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters are arranged by theme, not chronology. Chapter 34 is during the siege, when Zedekiah freed the slaves as a covenant and then took them back. Chapters 35 and 36 go back to the days of Jehoiakim, about 605 BC. They show a series of contrasts: a nation that would not keep its word, a clan that did, and a king who could not bear to hear God's word.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You recently repented and did what was right in my eyes... but then you turned around and profaned my name when each of you took back his male servant and his female servant" (34:15-16).
2. "You have not obeyed me by proclaiming liberty, every one to his brother" (34:17).
3. "The Rechabites, the descendants of Jonadab the son of Rechab, have kept the command that their father gave them, but this people has not obeyed me" (35:16).
4. "Because you have obeyed the command of Jonadab your father... Jonadab the son of Rechab shall never lack a man to stand before me" (35:18-19).
5. "Take a scroll and write on it all the words that I have spoken to you" (36:2).

6. “It may be that the house of Judah will hear all the disaster that I intend to do to them” (36:3).
7. “Neither the king nor any of his servants who heard all these words was afraid, nor did they tear their garments” (36:24).
8. “Then Jeremiah took another scroll and gave it to Baruch… who wrote on it all the words of the scroll that Jehoiakim king of Judah had burned in the fire” (36:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In chapter 34, the people showed a flash of obedience. Under siege, they freed their Hebrew slaves, as the law of Exodus 21 and Deuteronomy 15 required. They made a covenant in the temple, passing between the pieces of a calf. Then, when the Babylonian army withdrew for a moment, they took the slaves back. They had made a vow and broken it. God’s reaction is sharp: they profaned his name. The punishment fits the crime: you did not proclaim liberty, so I proclaim liberty to the sword, the pestilence, and the famine.

Chapter 35 offers a contrast. The Rechabites were a clan who, for generations, had obeyed their ancestor’s rule not to drink wine or build houses. Jeremiah sets wine before them in the temple and invites them to drink. They refuse. They have kept the word of a human father for two hundred years. And God says: you, my people, have not kept the word of your divine Father, spoken persistently. The point is not that abstaining from wine is holy, but that obedience to a spoken word is possible. If a family can keep a command for generations, God’s people should be able to keep his.

In chapter 36, Baruch writes Jeremiah’s words on a scroll and reads it in the temple. Officials are afraid and report it to the king. Jehoiakim sits by the fire in the winter house, and as the scroll is read he cuts it up with a knife and throws it in the fire, column by column. The contrast with Josiah, who tore his clothes at the Book of the Law, could not be clearer. But burning the scroll does not destroy the word. God tells Jeremiah to write it again “and many similar words were added to them.” The word of the LORD is indestructible.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 40:8 says, “The grass withers, the flower fades, but the word of our God will stand forever.” Matthew 24:35: “Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away.” Hebrews 4:12 says the word of God is living and active. John 14:15 says, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” James 1:22 says to be doers of the word. Luke 4:18-19 shows Jesus proclaiming liberty to captives.

STEP 6

Application

Examine whether there is a commitment you have made to God or to others that you have taken back.

Ask what you could do to be as faithful to God's word as the Rechabites were to their father's.

Pray for the preservation and spread of Scripture, and thank God for your own copy.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his word cannot be burned.

Confess vows you have broken.

Ask him to make you faithful in the small commitments.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 64

"I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you."

JEREMIAH 31:3

DAY 446 · WEEK 64

Jeremiah 37:1-39:18

Jeremiah in the cistern; Jerusalem falls; he is freed

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 59 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 37:1-39:18. These are the chapters of the final siege. Jeremiah is arrested, thrown into a cistern, rescued by a foreigner, and finally freed when Jerusalem falls. Read it as a story of faithfulness costing everything and being vindicated.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The final siege of Jerusalem lasted about eighteen months, from 588 to 586 BC. Jeremiah was accused of deserting to the enemy because he told people to surrender. He was beaten and imprisoned. The officials then dropped him into a muddy cistern to die. Chapter 39 records the city's fall, which the prophet had announced for forty years.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You are going over to the Chaldeans!" (37:13).
2. "Is there any word from the LORD? ... There is... You shall be delivered into the hand of the king of Babylon" (37:17).
3. "Then they took Jeremiah and cast him into the cistern... and Jeremiah sank in the mud" (38:6).
4. "Ebed-melech the Ethiopian, a eunuch... went from the king's house and said to the king, My lord the king, these men have done evil in all that they did to Jeremiah" (38:7-9).
5. "Obey now the voice of the LORD in what I say to you, and it shall be well with you" (38:20).
6. "In the ninth year of Zedekiah... a breach was made in the city" (39:1-2).

7. “The king of Babylon slaughtered the sons of Zedekiah at Riblah before his eyes… and put out the eyes of Zedekiah” (39:6-7).

8. “I will deliver you on that day, declares the LORD… because you have put your trust in me” (39:17-18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Zedekiah is the central tragic figure. He is afraid of the officials, afraid of the people, and afraid of the Babylonians. He wants Jeremiah’s counsel but will not follow it. He meets the prophet secretly and asks, “Is there any word from the LORD?” The answer is the same: surrender. “If you will go out… your life shall be spared.” But the fear of men is a snare. He says, “I am afraid of the Judeans who have deserted to the Chaldeans.” The king who might have saved the city is paralyzed.

The cistern scene is vivid. The officials, angry that Jeremiah is weakening morale, drop him in a muddy pit to die. He sinks into the mire. It is a picture of a righteous person abandoned. Then comes an unlikely rescuer: Ebed-melech, an Ethiopian official in the palace. He risks his own position to speak to the king, and he pulls Jeremiah out with ropes padded with old rags so that they do not cut his arms. A foreigner shows more mercy than the leaders of God’s people. He is promised in return: “I will surely save you.”

Chapter 39 is the long-awaited end. The wall is breached, the temple burned, Zedekiah’s sons killed before his eyes, and then his eyes put out. The prophet’s words come true in detail. Yet the Babylonian commander treats Jeremiah kindly. He is released and stays among the poor who are left in the land.

The story shows that faithfulness to God’s word can be costly, and that vindication, though sometimes slow, is sure. And it shows how God honors acts of faith and mercy, even from an outsider.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus was condemned by religious leaders who feared the people (Luke 22:2), and by Pilate who feared the crowd (John 19:12-16). A foreigner, Simon of Cyrene, carried his cross (Luke 23:26). Matthew 25:40 says that what you do for the least of these you do for him. Acts 8:26-39 records an Ethiopian official’s conversion. Proverbs 29:25 says, “The fear of man lays a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is safe.”

STEP 6

Application

Ask where the fear of man holds you back from obeying God.

Be an Ebed-melech this week: act on behalf of someone who is being treated unjustly, even at some cost.

Remember Jeremiah when you are faithful and it costs you. God sees.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the fear of man that has trapped you.
- Ask him for courage like Jeremiah's and compassion like Ebed-melech's.
- Thank him for delivering his servants.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 64

"I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you."

JEREMIAH 31:3

DAY 447 · WEEK 64

Psalm 107:23-43

Those who go down to the sea

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 107:23-43. Here are the sailors in the storm, and then a series of reversals in which God turns deserts into pools and the proud into the humble. Notice how the psalm ends with a wisdom saying.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second half of Psalm 107, which you began five days ago. The first half told of wanderers, prisoners, and the sick. This half begins with the sailors and then moves to a hymn of reversals. It is a fitting close to the story of Jeremiah's siege and fall, since it shows God as the one who humbles the proud and lifts the lowly. The psalm will return again later in the plan.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Some went down to the sea in ships, doing business on the great waters" (v. 23).
2. "They saw the deeds of the LORD, his wondrous works in the deep" (v. 24).
3. "He commanded and raised the stormy wind, which lifted up the waves of the sea" (v. 25).
4. "They reeled and staggered like drunken men and were at their wits" end' (v. 27).
5. "Then they cried to the LORD in their trouble, and he delivered them from their distress. He made the storm be still" (vv. 28-29).
6. "Then they were glad that need be still, and he brought them to their desired haven" (v. 30).
7. "He turns rivers into a desert, springs of water into thirsty ground" (v. 33).

8 “Whoever is wise, let him attend to these things; let them consider the steadfast love of the LORD” (v. 43).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sailors are the fourth group. Unlike the others, they are not in trouble by sin or by accident. They are doing their work, “doing business on the great waters,” and a storm comes. God himself “commanded and raised the stormy wind.” This reminds us that not all trouble is a punishment for sin. Sometimes God brings storms to show his deeds in the deep. The sailors reel like drunks and their courage melts. They are at their wits’ end, literally, “all their wisdom was swallowed up.” Then they cry out, and he stills the storm to a whisper. The haven they long for is his gift.

From verse 33, the psalm shifts to a broader picture of God’s rule. He turns rivers into deserts and deserts into pools. The change depends on the moral condition of the people: a fruitful land becomes salt because of the wickedness of its inhabitants. And he settles the hungry in a desert turned to pools. He blesses them so that they multiply. This is God’s rule of reversal: he brings princes into contempt and lifts the needy out of affliction and makes their families like flocks.

The statement in verse 42 is clear: “The upright see it and are glad, and all wickedness shuts its mouth.” The psalm closes with a wisdom call. “Whoever is wise, let him attend to these things.” The wise person reads history and life as the story of God’s steadfast love. In the context of the exile, the lesson is that the return will be a work of God, in the same pattern of rescue after crying out.

All four of the psalm’s stories describe the same truth: when we are at our wits’ end, we can cry out to the LORD, and he hears.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus calmed the storm with a word: “Peace! Be still!” (Mark 4:39), and the disciples asked, “Who then is this?” Psalm 107:29 gives the answer: the LORD. Jesus walked on water (Matthew 14:22-33). Luke 1:52-53 echoes the reversals: he has brought down the mighty and exalted the humble. 2 Corinthians 1:8-10 describes being so utterly burdened that we despaired of life, and God delivering us.

STEP 6

Application

Think about a storm you are in. Pray, “Lord, I am at my wits” end,’ and ask him to still it.

Consider that not every storm is a punishment. Look for what God may be showing you in it.

Take time to “attend to these things” by reviewing the rescues of this psalm, and thank God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God about the storm you are in and that you are at your wits’ end.
- Ask him to bring you to your desired haven.
- Thank Jesus, who stilled the storm.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 64

“I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you.”

JEREMIAH 31:3

DAY 448 · WEEK 64

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Jeremiah 31:3 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you."

JEREMIAH 31:3

REST

Meditation

This verse stands at the front of the great chapter of the new covenant. It is spoken to a people who have just lost everything. They had broken the covenant, and the covenant curses had fallen. Here is what God says first: "I have loved you."

"I have loved you with an everlasting love." The word "everlasting" goes back before time and extends beyond it. It is not a love that began when Israel obeyed or ended when they failed. It was there before they did anything. Paul says the same of believers: God chose us in Christ before the foundation of the world. His love is not based on our performance.

"Therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you." The word "therefore" is important. Because of his love, he continues to be faithful. The word for "continued" means to draw out or extend, like drawing a long line. God has stretched his faithfulness over the whole history of their rebellion. He has not given up. Judgment was a form of faithfulness to the covenant, and the promise of restoration is too.

Think of the context. The exiles heard this in Babylon. They might have thought that God's love had ended with the destruction of the temple. This verse says no. The love is everlasting. The exile does not change it.

For the Christian, the cross is the proof. "God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us." Romans 8:38-39 says that nothing can separate us from the love of God. Say this verse whenever you doubt that you are loved.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the heart of Jeremiah: the Book of Consolation. You read the promise of a new covenant, in which God will write his law on the hearts of his people, bring them all to know him, and forgive their sin and remember it no more. You read of Jeremiah's purchase of a field while the Babylonians besieged the city, a picture of faith in a future he could not see. You watched King Zedekiah's fear of men, Jeremiah in the cistern, and Ebed-melech's courage. You saw the Rechabites keep their vow, and a king burn God's word in a fire while the word survived. And you finished the first part with the fall of Jerusalem. In the psalms, you prayed Psalm 107, a song for the redeemed from every kind of trouble. The week taught that God keeps his promises even when everything seems lost, and that his love is everlasting.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The new covenant promises that God will write his law on our hearts. What part of obedience still feels like an outward duty to you rather than a desire, and how might you ask God to change that?

Jeremiah bought a field when the city was falling. What step of faith might God be asking you to take toward a future you cannot see?

Psalm 107 asks the redeemed to say so. Whose story of rescue could you tell this week, and who needs to hear it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his everlasting love and continued faithfulness.

Thank him for the new covenant in Jesus' blood.

Rest in him today.

DAY 449 · WEEK 65

Psalm 108

My heart is steadfast, O God

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 108. It is a psalm made of two earlier psalms, joined together. Notice the confident praise at the beginning and the honest need at the end.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 108 is a psalm of David, made from parts of two other psalms: verses 1 to 5 are almost identical to Psalm 57:7-11, and verses 6 to 13 are almost identical to Psalm 60:5-12. This was used in worship as a song for a nation facing enemies and hoping for God's help. It is a fitting prayer after the fall of Jerusalem, since it begins with praise and ends with trust in God alone when human help fails.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "My heart is steadfast, O God! I will sing and make melody with all my being!" (v. 1).
2. "Awake, O harp and lyre! I will awake the dawn!" (v. 2).
3. "I will give thanks to you, O LORD, among the peoples" (v. 3).
4. "For your steadfast love is great above the heavens; your faithfulness reaches to the clouds" (v. 4).
5. "Be exalted, O God, above the heavens! Let your glory be over all the earth!" (v. 5).
6. "That your beloved ones may be delivered, give salvation by your right hand and answer me!" (v. 6).
7. "Have you not rejected us, O God? You do not go out, O God, with our armies" (v. 11).
8. "Through God we will do valiantly; it is he who will tread down our foes" (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a vow. “My heart is steadfast.” The word means firm, fixed, established. Whatever is happening around him, his heart is anchored in God. And the result is song, with all his being. He even says he will wake the dawn, rather than waiting for morning to wake him. His praise is not tied to circumstances.

The praise then widens to include the nations: “among the peoples… among the nations.” God’s steadfast love is above the heavens, and so his praise must be heard everywhere. The psalmist’s confidence rests on God’s character. Notice the two terms again: steadfast love and faithfulness. They are the pillars of God’s covenant.

Then the psalm shifts to prayer and to a series of divine promises. God has spoken in his holiness: he will divide Shechem, measure the Valley of Succoth, and claim Gilead, Manasseh, Ephraim, and Judah. Moab is his washbasin, Edom his slave. These are the promises of the land, spoken to David. God will give victory.

But the last part is honest. “Who will lead me to the fortified city? Who will lead me to Edom? Have you not rejected us, O God?” The psalmist admits that the people are in trouble, that God does not seem to be going out with their armies. He pleads: “Oh grant us help against the foe, for vain is the salvation of man!” Human help fails. “Through God we will do valiantly.” The psalm ends with a statement of faith in the middle of weakness.

This is a good prayer for the exile and for every believer who is both confident and needy. We can praise the God whose love is above the heavens even as we ask for help in a world where our own strength fails.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 108’s praise among the nations is picked up in Romans 15:9-11. Ephesians 3:20 says God is able to do far more abundantly than all that we ask or think. Philippians 4:13 says, “I can do all things through him who strengthens me.” Psalm 20:7 says some trust in chariots, but we trust in the name of the LORD. John 15:5 says that apart from Christ we can do nothing.

STEP 6

Application

Start tomorrow morning with the vow of verse 2: “I will awake the dawn.” Sing or pray aloud before anything else.

Trust God, not human help, in an area where you have been leaning on your own plans.

Praise the LORD among someone who does not know him, by telling them one thing he has done.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God your heart is steadfast, or ask him to make it so.
- Sing or speak your praise to him in your own words.
- Ask him to be exalted above the heavens.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 65

"Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known."

JEREMIAH 33:3

DAY 450 · WEEK 65

Jeremiah 40:1-42:22

Gedaliah the governor; the people ask Jeremiah

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 59 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 40:1-42:22. After Jerusalem falls, a Babylonian-appointed governor is murdered, and the survivors ask Jeremiah what to do. Read their promise to obey in chapter 42, and notice what happens in chapter 43, which you will read tomorrow.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the destruction of 586 BC, Nebuchadnezzar appointed a Jewish governor, Gedaliah, at Mizpah to oversee the people who remained. Jeremiah chose to stay with them. Then a member of the royal family, Ishmael, assassinated Gedaliah and others. The remaining leaders were afraid of Babylonian reprisal and thought of fleeing to Egypt. They came to Jeremiah and asked for God's guidance.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The captain of the guard says, "The LORD your God pronounced this disaster against this place" (40:2).
2. Jeremiah chooses to stay: "Jeremiah went to Gedaliah... and lived with him among the people who were left in the land" (40:6).
3. "But Gedaliah the son of Ahikam would not believe them" (40:16).
4. Ishmael kills Gedaliah (41:2).
5. "Let the LORD your God show us the way we should go, and the thing that we should do" (42:3).
6. "Whether it is pleasant or unpleasant, we will obey the voice of the LORD our God" (42:6).

7. “If you will remain in this land, then I will build you up and not pull you down” (42:10).
8. “Do not go to Egypt… I solemnly warn you this day that you have gone astray at the cost of your lives” (42:19-20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Babylonian captain gives Jeremiah a choice: come to Babylon and be cared for, or stay in the land. Jeremiah stays with the poor. He had been faithful to God’s word in the city, and he stays faithful among the remnant. For a moment, there is hope. Gedaliah, a good man who protects the people, calls them to settle, serve Babylon, and gather the harvest of the land. The people return from the countries where they had fled, and for a short time there is a summer harvest of wine and fruit.

Then Ishmael, who had been warned, murders Gedaliah at a meal. The murder of the governor and the group around him is shocking, and Ishmael kills pilgrims on their way to the temple as well. Johanan rescues the captives, but he fears Babylon’s reaction.

Johanan and the people come to Jeremiah. Their request sounds pious: “Pray for us to the LORD your God… that the LORD your God may show us the way.” They promise to obey, whether it is good or bad. Jeremiah prays, and after ten days, God answers: stay. “Do not fear the king of Babylon.” If they stay, God will build them up. If they go to Egypt, the sword and famine they fear will follow them there.

The problem is in the heart. Jeremiah says, “You have deceived yourselves.” They had already decided to go to Egypt. They asked for God’s word, but they only wanted his approval. Asking for guidance when you have already decided is not seeking God. The promise to obey whatever he says is easy to make before you know the answer. True obedience begins when what God says is unwelcome.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said in Luke 6:46, “Why do you call me Lord, Lord, and not do what I tell you?” James 1:22-25 warns against hearing without doing. Proverbs 3:5-6 says to trust in the LORD with all your heart and to lean not on your own understanding. Matthew 7:21 says that not everyone who says “Lord, Lord” will enter the kingdom. John 7:17 says that anyone who wills to do God’s will shall know.

STEP 6

Application

Before you ask God for guidance on a decision, tell him honestly that you will obey whatever he says.

Notice whether you have already decided what you will do and are only asking for confirmation.

Be like Jeremiah this week: stay faithful in a hard place with those who have little.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to show you the way you should go.
- Tell him you will obey, whether pleasant or unpleasant.
- Ask him to keep you from deciding first and asking later.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 65

"Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known."

JEREMIAH 33:3

DAY 451 · WEEK 65

Jeremiah 43:1-45:5

Disobedience; the flight to Egypt; Baruch's consolation

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 37 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 43:1-45:5. The leaders refuse God's answer and flee to Egypt, taking Jeremiah with them. Then Jeremiah faces the people's idolatry in Egypt, and a short word is given to Baruch, his scribe. Read chapter 45 carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After God's answer in chapter 42, the leaders accuse Jeremiah of lying and carry off the whole remnant to Egypt. In Tahpanhes, a border town, they settle among other Judean refugees. Even there, they take up the worship of the Queen of Heaven. The prophet's last recorded sermons are directed at their stubbornness. Chapter 45 is a gentle word to Baruch, who had grown discouraged.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You are telling a lie. The LORD our God did not send you to say, Do not go to Egypt to live there" (43:2).
2. "So Johanan... and all the people did not obey the voice of the LORD" (43:4).
3. "Take some large stones and hide them in the mortar... in front of Pharaoh's palace in Tahpanhes" (43:9).
4. "Why do you provoke me to anger with the work of your hands, making offerings to other gods in the land of Egypt?" (44:8).
5. "We will not listen to you... we will do everything that we have vowed, make offerings to the queen of heaven" (44:16-17).
6. "For then we had plenty of bread, and prospered, and saw no disaster" (44:17).

7. “Behold, I am watching over them for disaster and not for good” (44:27).
8. “And do you seek great things for yourself? Seek them not, for behold, I am bringing disaster upon all flesh… but I will give you your life as a prize of war in all places to which you may go” (45:5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The people’s refusal is blunt. Having asked for God’s word and promised to obey, they now call Jeremiah a liar. The sin of unbelief is compounded by the sin of disobedience. They go to Egypt, the land God had delivered them from. It is a reversal of the exodus. The prophet is taken with them, and even there he continues to speak.

God’s word comes in the form of a sign: Jeremiah buries stones in the pavement in front of Pharaoh’s palace and says that Nebuchadnezzar will set his throne over them. The refuge they chose will not hold.

In chapter 44, the people in Egypt are defiant. When Jeremiah reproaches them for their idolatry, they give a revealing response. They claim that when they worshiped the Queen of Heaven, they had food and no disaster. It was only when they stopped, in Josiah’s reform, that trouble came. This is a classic example of misreading history. They say that the gods worked and the LORD did not. They are reading their own lives with no reference to God’s word. They refuse to repent and vow to continue.

Against this, chapter 45 is a short, tender word to Baruch. He had been in the thick of the struggle with Jeremiah, writing the scrolls and being threatened. He is weary and says, “Woe is me! For the LORD has added sorrow to my pain.” God’s reply is gentle but firm: “Do you seek great things for yourself? Seek them not.” This is not a time for personal ambition. Yet there is a promise: your life will be spared. Baruch’s life is a quiet example of faithful service in a time of collapse.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 6:46-49 contrasts the person who hears and does not act with the one who builds on rock. Matthew 6:33 says to seek first the kingdom of God, which echoes “seek not great things.” Luke 9:23-25 says that whoever would save his life will lose it. Philippians 2:3-4 calls us to count others more significant than ourselves. Hebrews 3:12-13 warns against an evil, unbelieving heart.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you ever read your life only through your own experience and not through God's word.

Think about whether you are "seeking great things" for yourself. What would it mean to be content with faithful, hidden service?

Encourage someone who is faithfully serving in a quiet role.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from a hard heart that calls his word a lie.
- Ask him to teach you to read your life through his word.
- Thank him for his patience.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 65

"Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known."

JEREMIAH 33:3

DAY 452 · WEEK 65

Jeremiah 46:1-48:47

Oracles against Egypt and Moab [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 46:1-48:47. This is a survey day. These are oracles against Egypt, the Philistines, and Moab. Do not worry about every name. Read for the repeated message: God is Lord of the nations, and pride is judged.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapters 46 to 51 are Jeremiah's oracles against the nations. Like Isaiah 13-23 and Ezekiel 25-32, they place the story of Judah inside God's rule over the world. The first oracle is against Egypt, tied to the battle of Carchemish in 605 BC. The next ones concern the Philistines and Moab, with echoes of Isaiah's earlier oracles on Moab. These oracles show that no nation escapes God's judgment and that some of them receive a promise of restoration.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Who is this, rising like the Nile, like rivers whose waters surge?" (46:7).
2. "Egypt rises like the Nile... I will surely punish Amon of Thebes, and Pharaoh" (46:8, 25).
3. "But fear not, O Jacob my servant, nor be dismayed, O Israel" (46:27).
4. "I will make a full end of all the nations among whom I have scattered you, but of you I will not make a full end" (46:28).
5. "Because you trusted in your works and your treasures, you also shall be taken" (48:7).
6. "We have heard of the pride of Moab... his insolence, his pride, and his arrogance" (48:29).
7. "Cursed is he who does the work of the LORD with slackness" (48:10).
8. "Yet I will restore the fortunes of Moab in the latter days, declares the LORD" (48:47).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The oracle against Egypt begins with a military scene: the Egyptian army at Carchemish, preparing for battle, and then fleeing in defeat. “Who is this, rising like the Nile?” The question has the same shape as Isaiah’s against Babylon. Egypt rose in pride, as a flood that covers the earth, but the LORD is greater. The oracle ends in 46:27-28 with comfort for Israel: “Fear not, O Jacob my servant.” God will discipline in just measure, but will not destroy his people.

The oracle against the Philistines in chapter 47 pictures waters from the north that sweep over the land, and the cries of fathers who do not turn to help their children. It is a picture of utter terror.

Chapter 48 is a long lament over Moab, the nation descended from Lot and often hostile to Israel. The reason for its fall is stated clearly: it trusted in its works and treasures, and in its pride. “Moab has been at ease from his youth… like wine left on its dregs.” A people that has never been disturbed grows complacent. The prophet’s sorrow is real: “Therefore I wail for Moab; I cry out for all Moab.” This is no gloating.

Notice 48:10: “Cursed is he who does the work of the LORD with slackness.” It is a warning to the executioners of judgment, but also to everyone. The work of the LORD is serious.

The chapter ends with a surprise. “Yet I will restore the fortunes of Moab in the latter days.” Even this enemy nation has a future. The God who judges the nations is the God who will bring them back. Jeremiah’s prophecies of judgment are never the last word.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 18 and 19 draw on the oracles against the nations for the fall of Babylon. Colossians 3:23 says, “Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord.” Revelation 21:24-26 says that the nations will bring their glory into the new Jerusalem. Ruth, a Moabite, was an ancestor of David and Jesus (Matthew 1:5). Acts 17:26-27 says God made all nations that they should seek him.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for a nation that is facing disaster or war.

Consider whether you have grown complacent, like wine left on its dregs, from too much ease.

Do one thing for the Lord with wholehearted effort today and not in slackness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as God of all nations.
- Pray for those who suffer under proud powers.
- Ask him not to let you grow complacent.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 65

"Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known."

JEREMIAH 33:3

DAY 453 · WEEK 65

Jeremiah 49:1-51:64

Oracles against Ammon, Edom, Babylon [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 117 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 49:1-51:64. This is another survey day, with oracles against Ammon, Edom, Damascus, Elam, and above all, Babylon. Read the Babylon oracle for its main theme: the empire that destroyed Jerusalem will itself be destroyed.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The long section of oracles ends with Babylon. Jeremiah's message to the exiles is that Babylon, God's instrument, will be punished for its own pride and cruelty. In 51:59-64, Jeremiah sends a scroll with Seraiah, a Judean official, who is to read the oracle in Babylon and then tie a stone to it and throw it into the Euphrates. Babylon fell in 539 BC, though not as dramatically as the prophecies suggest. The final fall is a symbol still awaited.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The pride of your heart has deceived you, you who live in the clefts of the rock" (49:16).
2. "I have heard a message from the LORD, and an envoy has been sent among the nations" (49:14).
3. "Declare among the nations and proclaim... Babylon is taken, Bel is put to shame, Merodach is dismayed" (50:2).
4. "In those days and in that time, declares the LORD, the people of Israel and the people of Judah shall come together, weeping as they come" (50:4).
5. "They shall ask the way to Zion, with faces turned toward it, saying, Come, let us join ourselves to the LORD in an everlasting covenant" (50:5).
6. "Their Redeemer is strong; the LORD of hosts is his name" (50:34).

7. “Babylon was a golden cup in the LORD’s hand, making all the earth drunken” (51:7).

8. “Flee from the midst of Babylon; let every one save his life!” (51:6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The oracles against the nations in chapter 49 follow familiar notes. Edom’s pride in its mountain strongholds will not save it. “Though you make your nest as high as the eagle’s, from there I will bring you down.” Damascus and Hazor and Elam will also fall.

Chapters 50 and 51 are a long poem on Babylon. The great empire that carried God’s people into exile is now the target. The reason is stated: Babylon sinned against the LORD, the Holy One of Israel. It exulted in its destruction of his heritage. Its gods, Bel and Merodach, will be put to shame. God uses a nation from the north, the Medes and Persians, to do it. Babylon will become a desolation.

But the poem is also about Israel. In the middle of the destruction, there is a promise for God’s people: they will come together, weeping, and seek the way to Zion. “Come, let us join ourselves to the LORD in an everlasting covenant that will never be forgotten.” This is the language of the new covenant. The prophet says that their sins will be sought for and not found: “For I will pardon those whom I leave as a remnant.” The people are called to leave Babylon. “Flee from the midst of Babylon… Be not cut off in her punishment.”

The image of Babylon as a golden cup in the LORD’s hand shows God’s control. The empire was an instrument, and when it has done its work, it is broken. The scroll sunk in the Euphrates ends the prophecy with an act of faith: “Thus shall Babylon sink, to rise no more.” The last line of the section is simple: “Thus far are the words of Jeremiah.”

In Scripture, Babylon is more than a city. It becomes the symbol of the world system in opposition to God. Revelation echoes these chapters in its portrayal of the fall of Babylon the great.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 18:4 says, “Come out of her, my people, lest you take part in her sins,” echoing Jeremiah 51:45. Revelation 14:8 and 18:2 declare “Fallen, fallen is Babylon the great.” Revelation 18:21 describes a millstone thrown into the sea, like Jeremiah’s scroll. Hebrews 8:8-12 confirms the “everlasting covenant” in Christ. 2 Corinthians 6:17 calls us to come out and be separate.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what “Babylon” looks like in your context: a system or value that opposes God. How are you called to live as a faithful exile?

Join in the prayer of Jeremiah 50:5: “Come, let us join ourselves to the LORD in an everlasting covenant.”

Remember that no empire lasts forever. Place your hope in the kingdom of God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is the Redeemer who judges proud powers.

Ask him to help you come out of whatever he calls you to leave.

Pray for his people living among empires.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 65

“Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known.”

JEREMIAH 33:3

DAY 454 · WEEK 65

Jeremiah 52:1-34

Jerusalem's fall retold, the historical anchor

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 34 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jeremiah 52:1-34. This last chapter retells the fall of Jerusalem and ends with a spark of hope. It is almost the same as 2 Kings 24-25. Read it as the book's historical anchor, proof that everything Jeremiah said came true.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The book of Jeremiah ends with this appendix, taken from 2 Kings. It does not add new teaching. It confirms that the prophecies were fulfilled in history. The date, the details, and even the numbers of the exiles are recorded. It ends where 2 Kings ends, with Jehoiachin released from prison. The writer wanted to show the reader that God's word is reliable, and that the exile is not the end.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Zedekiah was twenty-one years old when he began to reign... And he did what was evil in the sight of the LORD" (52:1-2).
2. "For because of the anger of the LORD it came to the point in Jerusalem and Judah that he cast them out from his presence" (52:3).
3. "In the ninth year of his reign... Nebuchadnezzar... came with all his army against Jerusalem" (52:4).
4. "So the city was besieged till the eleventh year of King Zedekiah" (52:5).
5. "And he burned the house of the LORD and the king's house and all the houses of Jerusalem" (52:13).

6. “The Chaldeans broke the bronze pillars… and carried all the bronze to Babylon” (52:17).
7. “Thus Judah was taken into exile out of its land” (52:27).
8. “Jehoiachin king of Judah… was released from prison… and he dined regularly at the king’s table all the days of his life” (52:31-33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter is almost dry in its detail: the dates, the lists, the weights of the bronze. This is the point. The prophecies of Jeremiah were not vague. They were specific, and the specifics came true. A prophet is tested by whether his words come to pass (Deuteronomy 18:22), and by this test, Jeremiah is vindicated, despite the opposition he faced.

The chapter reports the same terrible sequence as 2 Kings: the siege, the famine, the breach in the wall, the flight and capture of the king, the blinding, the burning of the temple, the breaking of the bronze pillars called Jachin and Boaz, and the deportation. The bronze pillars at the temple’s entrance, which had symbolized stability, are chopped up. The vessels of the temple are carried off. The number of those taken into exile in three waves is recorded: 3,023, then 832, then 745. These numbers are small. The nation has been reduced to a remnant.

There is one difference from 2 Kings: the date of the final release is stated, the twenty-fifth day of the twelfth month in the thirty-seventh year of exile, when Evil-merodach released Jehoiachin from prison. He is given a seat above the other kings in Babylon, a new set of clothes, and a daily allowance. It is a small mercy, and yet a sign. The line of David is alive.

Why end here? The book has told the whole story of judgment, but it wants the reader to see the tiny signs of hope. The final image is of a king in exile eating at a table. It is a promise in miniature: the God who judged is the God who preserves. For the faithful reader, this is the foretaste of the great feast that is coming.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 1:12 lists Jehoiachin (Jechoniah) in Jesus’ genealogy, and the line of David that seemed to end was continued in the one who is called Christ. Deuteronomy 18:21-22 gives the test of a true prophet. Hebrews 6:18-19 speaks of a hope that anchors the soul. Psalm 23:5 says, “You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies.” Revelation 19:9 says, “Blessed are those who are invited to the marriage supper of the Lamb.”

STEP 6

Application

Thank God that his word is always reliable, down to the last detail.

Look for the small signs of hope in a hard season: a table set in exile.

Reflect on how the line of David, nearly lost, led to Jesus. What does this teach you about God's faithfulness?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his word is true and comes to pass.

Thank him that in judgment he kept David's line alive.

Ask him to teach you to trust his promises.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 65

"Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known."

JEREMIAH 33:3

DAY 455 · WEEK 65

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Jeremiah 33:3 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known."

JEREMIAH 33:3

REST

Meditation

This verse was spoken to a man in prison. Jeremiah was locked in the court of the guard while Jerusalem burned. He had nothing: no freedom, no city, and no apparent future. And God said, "Call to me."

It is an invitation. The first thing God asks of someone in trouble is not to fix it but to call. Prayer is the simple act of speaking to God. No special words are required. The one who is in prison, who is at the end of his strength, can call.

"And I will answer you." It is a promise. The word for answer includes the sense of responding to someone who has spoken. God is not deaf or distant. He hears and replies. Not every answer comes in the form or on the schedule we expect. But he answers. He had already answered Jeremiah's earlier question by telling him to buy the field.

“And will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known.” This is a surprise. God offers more than relief. He offers revelation. “Great and hidden” might also be translated “fortified, inaccessible.” There are things that human wisdom cannot reach. In Jeremiah’s case, God goes on to reveal the restoration of Israel, the righteous Branch, and the everlasting covenant. They are the most glorious promises of the book, and they came in prison.

Say this verse when you feel confined. God often does his greatest teaching in the narrowest places. Call to him. He will answer, and he will show you more than you thought to ask.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the book of Jeremiah. You prayed Psalm 108, a song that begins with a steadfast heart and ends with trust in God because human help is vain. You read about the tragedy that followed the fall of Jerusalem: Gedaliah’s murder, the people’s request for God’s guidance that was already settled in their hearts, and their flight to Egypt in disobedience, where they took up idolatry again. You heard God’s quiet word to Baruch not to seek great things for himself. You read the oracles against Egypt, Moab, Edom, and above all Babylon, learning that no empire stands forever and even enemies have a future. And you read the closing chapter, which confirmed in history everything Jeremiah said and ended with Jehoiachin eating at the king’s table. The week taught that God’s word is reliable, that guidance requires willingness to obey, and that hope survives the fall.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The people asked Jeremiah for God’s guidance but had already decided. Is there a decision in your life where you are asking God but have not truly surrendered the answer?

Baruch was told not to seek great things for himself. Where do you struggle with wanting recognition for your service?

Jeremiah’s longest prophecies ended with a king eating at a table in exile. Where might God be giving you a small sign of hope in a difficult season?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Call to God and ask him to tell you great and hidden things.

Thank him for his reliable word.

Rest in him today.

DAY 456 · WEEK 66

Psalm 119:145-176

I cry with my whole heart; your word is my hope

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:145-176. This is the last two stanzas of the long acrostic psalm on God's word. You have read parts of Psalm 119 several times. Today read it as the prayer of a believer in exile, far from home but holding on to the word.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 119 is the longest chapter in the Bible, a poem of 176 verses in twenty-two stanzas, one for each letter of the Hebrew alphabet. Every verse speaks of God's word, using eight or so words for it: law, testimonies, precepts, statutes, commandments, rules, word, and promise. The last stanzas are written as a cry. The psalmist is pursued by persecutors and ends with an image of a lost sheep. It is a good psalm for the exile, as people without a temple clung to the written word.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "With my whole heart I cry; answer me, O LORD! I will keep your statutes" (v. 145).
2. "I rise before dawn and cry for help; I hope in your words" (v. 147).
3. "My eyes are awake before the watches of the night, that I may meditate on your promise" (v. 148).
4. "Those who persecute me with evil purpose draw near; they are far from your law. But you are near, O LORD" (vv. 150-151).
5. "Long have I known from your testimonies that you have founded them forever" (v. 152).

6. “The sum of your word is truth, and every one of your righteous rules endures forever” (v. 160).
7. “Great peace have those who love your law; nothing can make them stumble” (v. 165).
8. “I have gone astray like a lost sheep; seek your servant, for I do not forget your commandments” (v. 176).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalmist prays with his whole heart. He gets up before dawn and stays awake through the night, because his hope is in God’s word. In exile, the word of God was what remained. The temple was gone, the sacrifices ceased, but the written word could still be read, meditated on, and prayed. Many scholars believe the Scriptures became central to Jewish life in exile for this reason.

The situation is not easy. Persecutors are near, but the psalmist notes that “you are near, O LORD.” The enemy is close, but God is closer. The contrast is a source of strength. And he adds, “All your commandments are true.” Even when circumstances are hostile, the word does not change.

There is a beautiful summary in verse 160: “The sum of your word is truth.” The whole is true, and every part is true. The psalmist is not picking out the verses he likes. He has taken all of it. And the result is verse 165: “Great peace have those who love your law.” Peace, shalom, belongs to those who love the word. Nothing makes them stumble.

The last verse is surprising. After 175 verses of praise for the word, the psalmist confesses: “I have gone astray like a lost sheep.” It is an honest ending. He loves the word, and yet he knows he wanders. And his request is, “Seek your servant.” He does not say, “I will find my way back.” He asks the shepherd to find him. The word of God does not make us self-sufficient. It leads us to depend on the God who seeks.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I am the good shepherd” (John 10:11), and told the story of the shepherd who leaves ninety-nine sheep to seek the one that is lost (Luke 15:3-7). “I have come to seek and to save the lost” (Luke 19:10). 2 Timothy 3:16-17 says that all Scripture is breathed out by God. John 17:17 says, “Your word is truth.” John 14:27 gives Christ’s peace. 1 Peter 2:25: “You were straying like sheep, but have now returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls.”

STEP 6

Application

Set aside time before dawn this week, as the psalmist did, and cry to God from Scripture.

Memorize one verse of Psalm 119 that speaks to your situation.

Pray verse 176 as your own: “Seek your servant.” Thank Jesus for being the shepherd who finds.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Cry out to God with your whole heart.

Tell him your hope is in his word.

Thank him that he is near.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 66

“The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness.”

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

DAY 457 · WEEK 66

Psalm 120; Psalm 121

In my distress I called; I lift my eyes to the hills

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 120 and Psalm 121. These are the first two Songs of Ascents, which pilgrims sang on the way up to Jerusalem. Psalm 120 starts in distress far from home, and Psalm 121 lifts its eyes to the hills.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalms 120 to 134 are the Songs of Ascents, sung by pilgrims climbing to Jerusalem for the festivals. After the exile, they may also have been the songs of those returning. Psalm 120 begins in a foreign place: "Too long have I had my dwelling among those who hate peace." Psalm 121 is the voice of someone on the journey who asks where help comes from. They belong at this point in the plan as songs for exiles on the road home.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In my distress I called to the LORD, and he answered me" (120:1).
2. "Deliver me, O LORD, from lying lips, from a deceitful tongue" (120:2).
3. "Woe is me, that I sojourn in Meshech, that I dwell among the tents of Kedar!" (120:5).
4. "Too long have I had my dwelling among those who hate peace. I am for peace, but when I speak, they are for war" (120:6-7).
5. "I lift up my eyes to the hills. From where does my help come?" (121:1).
6. "My help comes from the LORD, who made heaven and earth" (121:2).
7. "He will not let your foot be moved; he who keeps you will not slumber" (121:3).
8. "The LORD will keep your going out and your coming in from this time forth and forevermore" (121:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 120 begins with a testimony and then a prayer. “In my distress I called to the LORD, and he answered me.” The psalmist remembers a time of rescue, and in the present he again needs it. His troubles are liars. Deceitful tongues surround him. He asks God to deal with them as arrows and burning coals. He is in a foreign place, Meshech and Kedar, far-off lands, a symbolic way of saying that he is among people who do not share his values. His last line is poignant: “I am for peace, but when I speak, they are for war.” It is the lament of anyone who longs for peace and meets hostility.

Psalm 121 is the answer. The pilgrim looks up at the hills of Judea. Some read the question as fear: the hills held pagan shrines and bandits. Others read it as longing for Zion. Either way, the answer is clear: “My help comes from the LORD, who made heaven and earth.” The one who made the hills is greater than they are. Help does not come from the landscape, but from its Creator.

Then the psalm uses a word again and again: keep. The LORD is your keeper. He will not let your foot slip. He does not sleep. He is your shade at your right hand. The sun will not strike you by day, nor the moon by night. He will keep your life. He will keep your going out and your coming in.

Together the two psalms give the journey of faith: from the foreign land of distress to the God who keeps. The travelers learn that their security does not depend on the road but on the one who walks it with them.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I will never leave you nor forsake you” (Hebrews 13:5, paraphrasing Deuteronomy 31:6), and “I am with you always” (Matthew 28:20). John 10:28 says that no one will snatch his sheep out of his hand. Jude 24 says he is able to keep you from stumbling. 1 Peter 1:5 says we are guarded by God’s power. Psalm 127 and Mark 4:38 remind us that Jesus slept in the boat, but the Father does not slumber. Romans 12:18 says, “If possible, so far as it depends on you, live peaceably with all.”

STEP 6

Application

When you are in distress, begin as Psalm 120 does: remember a past time that God answered you.

Pray Psalm 121 as a blessing over someone who is traveling or starting a new job.

When you feel surrounded by hostility, say aloud, “My help comes from the LORD, who made heaven and earth.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what distresses you and ask him to answer.
- Lift your eyes to him as your help.
- Thank him that he will keep you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 66

“The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness.”

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

DAY 458 · WEEK 66

Lamentations 1:1-2:22

Jerusalem's mourning; the city as widow

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Lamentations 1:1-2:22. The book of Lamentations is a collection of five poems of grief over the fall of Jerusalem. Read it slowly and honestly, without hurrying to the good news. Notice who is speaking in each part.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Lamentations was traditionally written by Jeremiah, though the text does not name an author. It follows the destruction of Jerusalem in 586 BC, and the five poems are written as acrostics: the first four use the Hebrew alphabet as a frame, a way of giving order to disorder. The book shows how to grieve in faith. It does not offer quick answers. It gives words for sorrow so that the people can bring it to God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "How lonely sits the city that was full of people! How like a widow has she become" (1:1).
2. "She weeps bitterly in the night, with tears on her cheeks; among all her lovers she has none to comfort her" (1:2).
3. "The LORD has afflicted her for the multitude of her transgressions" (1:5).
4. "Is it nothing to you, all you who pass by? Look and see if there is any sorrow like my sorrow" (1:12).
5. "The LORD is in the right, for I have rebelled against his word" (1:18).
6. "The Lord has become like an enemy; he has swallowed up Israel" (2:5).

7. “My eyes are spent with weeping; my stomach churns; my bile is poured out to the ground” (2:11).
8. “Arise, cry out in the night, at the beginning of the night watches! Pour out your heart like water before the presence of the Lord!” (2:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening line is among the saddest in the Bible. “How lonely sits the city that was full of people!” Jerusalem is pictured as a widow, once great among the nations and now a slave. She weeps in the night. Her friends have betrayed her. Her roads mourn because no one comes to the festivals. Her priests groan, her young women grieve. And no one comforts her.

The poem speaks in two voices: the narrator, who looks at the city and describes her pain, and Jerusalem herself, who speaks from verse 9 on. “Look, O LORD, and see, for I am despised.” The most piercing cry is in verse 12: “Is it nothing to you, all you who pass by?” It is the cry of someone suffering whose pain is invisible to the busy.

Yet already in chapter 1 there is honesty about the cause. “The LORD is in the right, for I have rebelled against his word.” The poet does not blame God for injustice. He confesses, and still he cries for help. Grief and repentance go together.

Chapter 2 is more shocking. The speaker says that the Lord himself has become like an enemy. The language is of God’s anger: he has torn down the stronghold, rejected his altar, and scorned his sanctuary. This was the hardest thing for the exiles to accept: God had done this. Yet the point of the poem is that God is real and his word is true.

The turning point is verse 19: “Arise, cry out in the night… pour out your heart like water before the presence of the Lord!” The right response to sorrow is to bring it to God. Lamentations teaches us that lament is a form of prayer, and that to pour out our hearts to God is itself an act of faith.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus wept over Jerusalem and said, “How often would I have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you were not willing!” (Luke 13:34). On the road to Golgotha, he told the women, “Do not weep for me, but weep for yourselves” (Luke 23:28). Romans 12:15 says, “Weep with those who weep.” Hebrews 5:7 says Jesus offered up prayers with loud cries and tears. Matthew 5:4: “Blessed are those who mourn, for they shall be comforted.”

STEP 6

Application

Spend time grieving something you have lost, without trying to fix it. Pour it out to God.

Be present with someone who is suffering. Do not hurry them. Sit with them.

Pray with the words of Lamentations 2:19 when you cannot find your own.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pour out your heart to God, naming a sorrow.
- Confess where you have rebelled against his word.
- Ask him to look on your affliction.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 66

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

DAY 459 · WEEK 66

Lamentations 3:1-66

"Great is your faithfulness", hope in the midst of suffering

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Lamentations 3:1-66. This is the center of the book, a long poem in which the poet moves from despair to a stunning declaration of hope. Read verses 19 to 33 slowly. They are the heart of the book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 3 is the only chapter in which the speaker is an individual, "the man who has seen affliction." It is a triple acrostic, in which three verses in a row begin with each letter of the Hebrew alphabet, making 66 verses. Its structure of increasing order is placed over its disorder. At the center, the poet speaks of hope in the middle of suffering.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I am the man who has seen affliction under the rod of his wrath" (v. 1).
2. "He has driven and brought me into darkness without any light" (v. 2).
3. "He has besieged me and surrounded me with bitterness and tribulation" (v. 5).
4. "So I say, My endurance has perished; so has my hope from the LORD" (v. 18).
5. "But this I call to mind, and therefore I have hope" (v. 21).
6. "The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness" (vv. 22-23).
7. "The LORD is my portion, says my soul, therefore I will hope in him" (v. 24).
8. "For he does not afflict from his heart or grieve the children of men" (v. 33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter opens in complete darkness. The speaker catalogs his suffering: God has walled him in, bound him with heavy chains, shut out his prayer, made his path crooked. He is like a bear or a lion lying in wait. The images are of a person who feels that God himself has become his enemy. And he reaches the bottom in verse 18: "My endurance has perished; so has my hope from the LORD."

Then comes the hinge: "But this I call to mind." The word "call to mind" means to bring back to the heart. He does not argue himself out of his pain. He remembers something. And what he remembers is the character of God. "The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

This is among the best known passages in Lamentations, and it is worth noting where it appears: in the center of the book of grief, in the aftermath of the destruction of Jerusalem. These are not words from a place of comfort. They are words from the ashes. The faithfulness of God is great precisely when everything else is gone.

The poet continues: "The LORD is my portion... therefore I will hope in him." He has lost everything but has God. It is good to wait quietly for the salvation of the LORD. It is good to bear the yoke in youth. God's discipline is not endless: "Though he cause grief, he will have compassion according to the abundance of his steadfast love." And he adds a statement that gives light to everything: "He does not afflict from his heart." Judgment is God's "strange work." His heart is mercy.

The rest of the chapter returns to prayer and to a plea for justice. But the poem has made its point: hope is a decision to remember who God is.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 4:15-16 says we have a high priest who can sympathize with our weaknesses. 2 Corinthians 4:8-9 says we are afflicted but not crushed. Hebrews 12:5-11 explains that the Lord disciplines the one he loves. Romans 5:3-5 says that suffering produces endurance, character, and hope. Isaiah 53:3 describes Jesus as a man of sorrows. The hymn "Great Is Thy Faithfulness" is based on verses 22 and 23.

STEP 6

Application

Start each day this week by saying, "His mercies are new every morning."

Think of a time of affliction when you remembered something about God that gave you hope. Write it down.

Wait quietly before God for a few minutes, as verse 26 teaches.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God how weary you are.

Call to mind his steadfast love and mercies, and name one.

Tell him you wait for him because he is good.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 66

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

DAY 460 · WEEK 66

Lamentations 4:1-5:22

The city's degradation; the final plea, restore us

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Lamentations 4:1-5:22. The last two poems describe the siege in horrifying detail and end with a communal prayer. Read the last chapter as a prayer for the people to say together, and notice the unsettled final verses.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 4 is a fourth acrostic and a description of the city's degradation: children starving, nobles in rags, prophets and priests defiled. Chapter 5 is not an acrostic, though it has 22 verses. It is a prayer for the whole community, a plea to remember what has happened and restore them. It ends without resolution, with a question. The book of Lamentations is meant to be read in its brokenness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "How the gold has grown dim, how the pure gold is changed!" (4:1).
2. "The tongue of the nursing infant sticks to the roof of its mouth for thirst; the children beg for food, but no one gives to them" (4:4).
3. "The punishment of the daughter of my people has been greater than the punishment of Sodom" (4:6).
4. "This was for the sins of her prophets and the iniquities of her priests" (4:13).
5. "Remember, O LORD, what has befallen us; look, and see our disgrace!" (5:1).
6. "Our fathers sinned, and are no more; and we bear their iniquities" (5:7).
7. "The joy of our hearts has ceased; our dancing has been turned to mourning" (5:15).

8 “Restore us to yourself, O LORD, that we may be restored! Renew our days as of old” (5:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 4 begins with a symbol of dimmed gold, used for the precious stones of the temple, now scattered at the head of every street. The precious sons of Zion, “worth their weight in fine gold,” are regarded as clay pots. Even jackals nurse their young, but the daughters of Jerusalem are cruel like ostriches in the wilderness. The poet describes starvation, even to the point of cannibalism, which Deuteronomy 28 had warned of. Nothing is spared.

The cause is again the sin of the leaders: “the sins of her prophets and the iniquities of her priests, who shed in the midst of her the blood of the righteous.” The people who should have led them to God led them astray.

The last chapter turns from description to prayer. “Remember, O LORD, what has befallen us.” The community pleads. They list their losses: inheritance turned over to strangers, orphans without fathers, water bought for money, wood sold at a price, slaves ruling over them. They acknowledge, “Woe to us, for we have sinned!” But they also affirm God’s rule: “But you, O LORD, reign forever; your throne endures to all generations.” Even in disaster, the throne of God is secure. This is the anchor of the book.

The prayer ends with a petition: “Restore us to yourself, O LORD, that we may be restored!” The initiative is God’s. They cannot return by themselves. Repentance itself is a gift. And then the book ends with a question that remains open: “Or have you utterly rejected us? Are you exceedingly angry with us?” Jewish tradition repeats verse 21 after the last verse, so as not to end on a note of despair. The unsettled ending is honest. It leaves the reader waiting for the answer, which the prophets Ezekiel and Daniel, and eventually Christ, will give.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 12:2 says Jesus endured the cross for the joy set before him. Revelation 21:4 promises that God will wipe away every tear. Acts 3:19-20 says, “Repent, therefore, and turn back, that your sins may be blotted out, that times of refreshing may come from the presence of the Lord.” 2 Corinthians 7:10 says godly grief produces repentance that leads to salvation. Romans 8:35-39 assures us that nothing can separate us from God’s love.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for a place where there is famine or war, and give practically if you can.

Use the prayer of 5:21: “Restore us to yourself, O LORD, that we may be restored.” Pray it for yourself and for your church.

Rest in the truth that God’s throne endures even when ours do not.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to remember his people and restore them.

Tell him he reigns forever.

Ask him to turn you back to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 66

“The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness.”

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

DAY 461 · WEEK 66

Ezekiel 1:1-3:27

The vision of God's throne, glory above the exile

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 1:1-3:27. A priest in exile by a canal in Babylon sees a vision of God's throne, eats a scroll, and is made a watchman. Read chapter 1 as a picture rather than a puzzle, and ask what it tells Ezekiel about where God is.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ezekiel was a priest, taken to Babylon with the first group of exiles in 597 BC, together with King Jehoiachin. In the fifth year of that exile, at the age of thirty, the age when priests began their service, he saw the vision. He had no temple to serve in, but God came to him by the river Chebar in a foreign land. Ezekiel prophesied for about twenty-two years, and his book is full of visions and sign-acts.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The heavens were opened, and I saw visions of God" (1:1).
2. "Out of the midst of it came the likeness of four living creatures" (1:5).
3. "And above the expanse over their heads there was the likeness of a throne, in appearance like sapphire" (1:26).
4. "Such was the appearance of the likeness of the glory of the LORD. And when I saw it, I fell on my face" (1:28).
5. "Son of man, stand on your feet, and I will speak with you" (2:1).
6. "And whether they hear or refuse to hear… they will know that a prophet has been among them" (2:5).

7. “Son of man, eat whatever you find here. Eat this scroll… and it was in my mouth as sweet as honey” (3:1, 3).

8. “Son of man, I have made you a watchman for the house of Israel” (3:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Ezekiel’s first vision is overwhelming, and all details point to one great truth: God is on his throne, and he is not confined to Jerusalem. A great storm cloud comes from the north, with flashing fire. Within it are four living creatures with faces of a man, a lion, an ox, and an eagle. Beside each is a wheel within a wheel, full of eyes, moving in every direction. Above is an expanse like crystal, and above that a throne with a figure like a man, surrounded by a rainbow. It is the glory of the LORD.

The point of the vision is clear to anyone who knows the situation. The exiles thought God had stayed in the temple in Jerusalem. They were in a foreign land, far from his presence. But God’s throne is mobile. It comes to Babylon. He is not limited to one place. The wheels move in any direction. He is sovereign over the whole earth.

Ezekiel falls on his face. God calls him “son of man,” a title used about ninety times in the book, emphasizing his humble humanity. He is raised by the Spirit and sent to a people who are “rebellious,” “hard of heart” and “stubborn.” The prophet is warned that they will not listen. His job is to speak, whether they hear or not.

Then he eats a scroll with words of lament, mourning, and woe, and it tastes sweet as honey. The word of God is sweet even when its message is bitter. In the Bible, to eat the word is to take it fully in before speaking it.

At the end of chapter 3, God makes him a watchman. If he warns, and they do not listen, he has saved himself. If he does not warn, he will be held accountable. The prophet is given seven days of silence, overwhelmed by the task. And then God binds his tongue, so that he speaks only when God gives him a word.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 4:6-8 shows four living creatures around the throne, and Revelation 1:12-18 shows the glorified Christ. John 1:14 says the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, “and we have seen his glory.” Matthew 28:19-20 sends the disciples into all the world and promises his presence. Revelation 10:8-11 shows John eating a scroll, as Ezekiel did. Acts 20:26-31 shows Paul acting as a watchman, innocent of the blood of all.

STEP 6

Application

Pause and remember that God is not confined to the places you associate with him. Pray to him wherever you are today.

Eat the word: take a short passage and read it slowly until you taste it.

Think about whom God has made you a watchman for: family, friends, a church. How are you warning and encouraging them?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for being seated on his throne.
- Thank him that he came to the exiles in Babylon, and to you.
- Ask him to give you ears to hear his word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 66

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

DAY 462 · WEEK 66

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Lamentations 3:22-23 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23

REST

Meditation

Few verses have comforted more people in grief than this one. It is surprising because of where it appears: in the center of a book of mourning over a destroyed city.

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases." The word for steadfast love, hesed, is the covenant word. It means loyal, faithful, committed love. It is the love of God that holds to the covenant even when his people have broken it. And "never ceases" means that it does not run out, even after disaster. The city has fallen, but God's love has not. The people had been tempted to think that they had exhausted God's patience. This verse says that his love is not a resource that can be used up.

"His mercies never come to an end." Mercies are acts of compassion, plural, as in many small acts. They are tender, like a mother's compassion for a child. They never come to an end. The two phrases say the same thing in two ways, as Hebrew poetry often does: God's love and compassion are inexhaustible.

“They are new every morning.” Each day brings fresh supplies. The mercy we need for today is not leftover mercy from yesterday. It is given new. This is a daily rhythm. We do not need to carry yesterday’s failures or tomorrow’s worries, because mercy is renewed with every sunrise.

“Great is your faithfulness.” The conclusion is a statement of praise, which gives us the title of the famous hymn. Faithfulness is God’s reliability. He keeps his word. Say this verse every morning this week, as you wake. Let it set the tone for the day.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you moved from the end of Jeremiah into the exile itself. You prayed Psalm 119’s closing stanzas as the prayer of one who clings to God’s word and then confesses that he is a lost sheep, and the first two Songs of Ascents, which move from distress to the confidence that the LORD is our keeper. You read all five poems of Lamentations, which give words for grief: the weeping widow, the cry of “Is it nothing to you?”, the center that remembers God’s steadfast love, and the final plea, “Restore us to yourself, O LORD.” Then you began Ezekiel, a priest in exile, who saw the glory of God on a mobile throne in Babylon, ate a scroll that tasted sweet as honey, and was made a watchman. The week taught that grief is a form of prayer, that God’s mercy is new every morning, and that God is present even in exile.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Lamentations gives a voice to grief. What sorrow have you not yet brought to God in prayer, and what might it look like to do so?

The hope in the center of Lamentations comes from remembering who God is. What is one truth about God’s character that has held you in a hard time?

Ezekiel saw God’s glory in a foreign land. Where do you feel far from God, and how does this vision speak to that place?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his mercies are new every morning.

Name a way he was faithful this week.

Rest in him today.

DAY 463 · WEEK 67

Psalm 73

Asaph was nearly slipping; then he entered the sanctuary

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 73. A believer almost loses his faith because the wicked seem to prosper. You have read this psalm before. Read it now as the prayer of someone in exile, who has lost the temple but finds God's presence anyway.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 73 is the first psalm of Book 3, a psalm of Asaph. It begins with a confession: "But as for me, my feet had almost stumbled." The psalmist envied the arrogant when he saw their ease. The turning point is when he entered "the sanctuary of God." For the exiles, the question was sharper: what could it mean to enter the sanctuary when the sanctuary was a ruin? The psalm answers that what matters is the presence of God himself.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Truly God is good to Israel, to those who are pure in heart" (v. 1).
2. "But as for me, my feet had almost stumbled, my steps had nearly slipped" (v. 2).
3. "For I was envious of the arrogant when I saw the prosperity of the wicked" (v. 3).
4. "All in vain have I kept my heart clean and washed my hands in innocence" (v. 13).
5. "But when I thought how to understand this, it seemed to me a wearisome task, until I went into the sanctuary of God; then I discerned their end" (vv. 16-17).
6. "I was brutish and ignorant; I was like a beast toward you" (v. 22).
7. "Nevertheless, I am continually with you; you hold my right hand" (v. 23).
8. "Whom have I in heaven but you? And there is nothing on earth that I desire besides you" (v. 25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is autobiographical. The writer was a believer who nearly gave up. He looked around and saw that the arrogant seemed to have no pain. Their bodies were fat, they were free from burdens, they spoke with malice, and they said, “How can God know?” Meanwhile, he had kept his heart clean, and had been plagued all day long. It seemed that holiness was in vain.

This is the question of the whole book of Jeremiah and Lamentations too. Why do the wicked prosper and the faithful suffer? The psalmist says that he tried to figure it out, but it was too hard for him. “Until I went into the sanctuary of God.” In God’s presence, his view changed. He saw the end of the wicked: slippery ground, sudden ruin. And he saw himself. He realized that his envy had made him “brutish and ignorant.” The sanctuary did not give him a theory. It gave him God.

Then comes the great turn. “Nevertheless, I am continually with you; you hold my right hand.” The psalmist realizes that his security was never that he held God, but that God held him. And he declares: “Whom have I in heaven but you? And there is nothing on earth that I desire besides you.” God is the one thing that cannot be lost. “My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever.”

For the exiles, there was no sanctuary in Jerusalem to enter. But there was the sanctuary of God’s presence, which Ezekiel had just seen by the river Chebar. To “enter the sanctuary” is to come into God’s presence and see things from his perspective. The psalm ends with a summary: “For me it is good to be near God.” It is a mark of mature faith. The best thing is not the removal of trouble but nearness to God.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Fear not, little flock, for it is your Father’s good pleasure to give you the kingdom” (Luke 12:32). Hebrews 10:19-22 says we may enter the holy places by the blood of Jesus. Philippians 3:7-8 says that Paul counted everything as loss compared to knowing Christ. John 10:28-29 says no one can snatch us out of the Father’s hand. Matthew 5:8 says the pure in heart will see God. 2 Corinthians 4:17-18 contrasts the momentary affliction with eternal glory.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a time you envied someone. Take that envy into the sanctuary of God’s presence in prayer, and ask what he shows you.

Say verse 25 aloud, and ask whether it is true: “Whom have I in heaven but you?”

Thank God that he holds your right hand when you cannot hold his.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess your envy and tell God where your feet nearly slipped.
- Tell him what you saw when you entered his presence.
- Tell him he is the strength of your heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 67

“My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever.”

PSALM 73:26

DAY 464 · WEEK 67

Psalm 77

I cry aloud to God; then I remember

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 77. You have read this psalm twice before, in Unit 6 and in Unit 11. Read it a third time as a prayer for the exile, and notice the line about God's footprints. This time hold it beside Ezekiel's vision of the chariot throne you have just read.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 77 is a psalm of Asaph. Earlier readings looked at it as a lesson in remembering, and as the lament of the northern kingdom. Now, in the exile, a third reading is possible. Ezekiel has just seen that God's throne moves on wheels and is not tied to Jerusalem. The psalmist says God's way was through the sea, and his footprints were unseen. God is at work even when we cannot trace him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I cry aloud to God, aloud to God, and he will hear me" (v. 1).
2. "In the day of my trouble I seek the Lord; in the night my hand is stretched out without wearying" (v. 2).
3. "Selah" appears after verses 3, 9, and 15, three pauses (vv. 3, 9, 15).
4. "Has God forgotten to be gracious? Has he in anger shut up his compassion?" (v. 9).
5. "I will ponder all your work, and meditate on your mighty deeds" (v. 12).
6. "Your way, O God, is holy. What god is great like our God?" (v. 13).
7. "You are the God who works wonders; you have made known your might among the peoples" (v. 14).

8 “Your way was through the sea, your path through the great waters; yet your footprints were unseen” (v. 19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three Selahs mark three pauses in the psalm, and they trace a journey. The first, after verse 3, comes after the psalmist says that remembering God makes him groan. The second, after verse 9, follows the string of questions about God’s compassion. The third, after verse 15, comes after the declaration that God has redeemed his people. The psalm moves from groaning, to doubt, to testimony, and each pause gives time to think.

The center of the psalm is verse 13: “Your way, O God, is holy.” The Hebrew can also mean, “Your way is in the sanctuary.” Both are true. God’s way is holy, set apart and pure. And it is found in his presence, not in our understanding. When the psalmist cannot explain what God is doing, he does not deny his goodness. He says the way is holy. He may not see all of it, but he trusts it.

This fits what Ezekiel saw. The living creatures and wheels moved in every direction, full of eyes. God sees all. His movements are not random, even though they are beyond our grasp. When the exiles felt that God had lost control, Ezekiel showed them his throne in the midst of the storm.

The final image of the psalm is quiet. “Your way was through the sea, your path through the great waters; yet your footprints were unseen.” God passed through the sea, but left no trace. And then the last line: “You led your people like a flock by the hand of Moses and Aaron.” The great Redeemer led through two ordinary men.

In the exile, God was still leading, through prophets like Ezekiel, through the hidden hand of providence, through the covenant he had promised not to forget. The footprints were unseen, but he was walking ahead.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 11:33 says, “How unsearchable are his judgments and how inscrutable his ways!” Job 23:8-10 expresses the same hiddenness: “If I go forward, he is not there… but he knows the way that I take.” Isaiah 55:8-9 says that his thoughts are higher than ours. Luke 24:13-35 shows Jesus walking beside the disciples unrecognized on the road to Emmaus. Romans 8:28 says that God works all things together for good. John 13:7: “What I am doing you do not understand now, but afterward you will understand.”

STEP 6

Application

Look back at a hard period and ask where God's footprints might have been unseen at the time.

Trace one "pause" in your own faith: groaning, doubt, or testimony. Where are you now?

Pray "Your way, O God, is holy" as an act of trust in something you do not understand.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Cry aloud to God, and tell him what troubles you.

Remember his wonders and rest on them.

Praise him as the God who works wonders.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 67

"My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever."

PSALM 73:26

DAY 465 · WEEK 67

Ezekiel 4:1-7:27

Signs of Jerusalem's siege; judgment is certain

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 92 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 4:1-7:27. God commands Ezekiel to act out the siege of Jerusalem in strange and difficult ways. Read these chapters as sermons without words, and then listen to the words in chapters 6 and 7, which say that the end has come.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ezekiel's early prophecies, from 593 to 586 BC, are warnings of the fall of Jerusalem. The exiles in Babylon hoped that the city would be spared. Ezekiel's task was to break that false hope. The sign-acts in chapter 4 and 5 are acted out for the exiles. He is bound, silent, and lying on his side, while they watch. The message is that the siege is coming and God himself is the enemy.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Take a brick and lay it before you and engrave on it a city, even Jerusalem" (4:1).
2. "Then lie on your left side… and I will lay the punishment of the house of Israel upon you" (4:4).
3. "And behold, I will put cords upon you, so that you cannot turn from one side to the other" (4:8).
4. "This is Jerusalem. I have set her in the center of the nations, with countries all around her" (5:5).
5. "Behold, I, even I, am against you" (5:8).
6. "And they shall know that I am the LORD" (6:7, a repeated refrain).
7. "An end! The end has come upon the four corners of the land" (7:2).

8 “Their silver and gold cannot deliver them in the day of the wrath of the LORD” (7:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Ezekiel’s sign-acts are strange. He draws Jerusalem on a clay brick and sets up a model siege around it. He lies on his left side for 390 days to bear the iniquity of Israel, and on his right side for 40 days for Judah. He eats rationed food baked over dung, a symbol of the defilement of exile. He shaves his head and beard with a sword and divides the hair into thirds: burned, struck with the sword, and scattered to the wind. The meaning is clear. Jerusalem will be besieged, starved, and destroyed. Only a few will survive.

The reason is in 5:5-8. Jerusalem was set in the center of the nations, to be a light. Instead, she has been more rebellious than the nations around her. “Therefore thus says the Lord GOD: Behold, I, even I, am against you.” This is the stark reality: the one who had fought for Jerusalem is now fighting against her.

Chapter 6 addresses the mountains, because the people worshiped on the high places. It is an oracle to the land itself: the idols will be broken and the bones scattered. The refrain begins to appear: “Then you will know that I am the LORD.” This phrase occurs about sixty-five times in Ezekiel. The purpose of everything is the knowledge of God. Judgment and later salvation both serve this end.

Chapter 7 announces the end: “An end! The end has come.” The language is of a flood approaching. No one will go to battle, because God’s wrath is on all the multitude. Money and gold will be worthless. Famine and plague will fill the city. Even the temple will be profaned.

Why does Ezekiel tell us all this? Because the exiles needed to know that God does not lose control. The destruction of the temple was not a defeat for God. It was an act of God, the same God who loves them, and who will, in later chapters, restore.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus predicted the siege of Jerusalem in Luke 19:43-44 and Luke 21:20-24. In Mark 13, he warns that not one stone will be left. Hebrews 12:25-29 says our God is a consuming fire. John 8:28 shows that people will know who he is when the Son of Man is lifted up. Romans 11:22: “Note then the kindness and the severity of God.” Revelation 6:15-17 describes people hiding from the wrath of the Lamb.

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on the gravity of sin. Take time to confess something you might be treating lightly.

Ask what God might be teaching you through the “acts” of your own life, such as your family, work, and church.

Remember that every judgment in Ezekiel serves the purpose that people will know the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from treating his word lightly.
- Ask him to teach you to fear him.
- Tell him you know judgment is real.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 67

“My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever.”

PSALM 73:26

DAY 466 · WEEK 67

Ezekiel 8:1-11:25

The glory departs from the Temple

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 96 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 8:1-11:25. In a vision, Ezekiel is carried to Jerusalem and sees the idolatry inside the temple. Then the glory of the LORD leaves. Read it slowly, and let the departure of the glory register. Then read the promise at the end of chapter 11.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In 592 BC, Ezekiel is sitting in his house with the elders of Judah when the Spirit lifts him up in a vision to the temple in Jerusalem. He sees four abominations, each worse than the last. Then the glory of the LORD, which had dwelt in the temple since Solomon dedicated it, rises from the cherubim and moves out of the city. This is the central event of the first part of Ezekiel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Son of man, do you see what they are doing, the great abominations that the house of Israel are committing here, to drive me far from my sanctuary?" (8:6).
2. "Every form of creeping things and loathsome beasts, and all the idols of the house of Israel, engraved on the wall all around" (8:10).
3. "They say, The LORD does not see us, the LORD has forsaken the land" (8:12).
4. "Behold, there sat women weeping for Tammuz" (8:14).
5. "Mark the foreheads of the men who sigh and groan over all the abominations that are committed in it" (9:4).
6. "Then the glory of the LORD went out from the threshold of the house" (10:18).

7 “And I will give them one heart, and a new spirit I will put within them. I will remove the heart of stone from their flesh and give them a heart of flesh” (11:19).

8 “And the glory of the LORD went up from the midst of the city and stood on the mountain that is on the east side of the city” (11:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Ezekiel is shown four scenes of corruption in the temple. First, an idol of jealousy at the north gate. Second, seventy elders of Israel offering incense to carved creatures on the walls, saying, “The LORD does not see us.” Third, women weeping for Tammuz, a fertility god. Fourth, twenty-five men with their backs to the temple, bowing to the sun in the east. The leaders, the priests, the women, and the men are all involved. The house built for the worship of the one true God is a pantheon of idols.

God’s response is judgment. In chapter 9, a man in linen marks the foreheads of those who grieve over the abominations. They will be spared. Then others follow to strike. It is a picture of discerning judgment. Even in the midst of destruction, God knows those who are his.

Then comes the heartbreaking departure of the glory. In chapter 10, Ezekiel sees the cherubim and wheels again, and the glory of the LORD rises from the threshold. It moves in stages: from the cherubim to the threshold, to the east gate, up from the city and onto the Mount of Olives. It is an act of reluctant departure. The glory leaves slowly. It is as though God lingers, hoping that they will turn.

In the midst of judgment, in chapter 11, the promise breaks through. God will gather them from the nations. He will remove the heart of stone and give a heart of flesh, with one heart and a new spirit. “Then they will be my people, and I will be their God.” Even though the temple is empty, he promises to be “a sanctuary for a little while” in the countries where they have gone.

This is the theological center: the presence of God is not tied to a building. And it points forward to a day when God’s glory will return, not to a stone temple but to a people with new hearts.

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:14 says the Word became flesh and “tabernacled” among us, and we have seen his glory. The glory that left the temple through the east gate stood on the Mount of Olives. Jesus ascended from the Mount of Olives (Acts 1:9-12) and will return there (Zechariah 14:4). 1

Corinthians 3:16 says that believers are God's temple. Revelation 7:3 and 9:4 echo the sealing of foreheads. 2 Corinthians 3:3 says we are a letter written on hearts of flesh.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what "idols in the temple" might be in your life: hidden things you do where you think God does not see.

Remember that God knows those who sigh and groan over sin. Do you grieve over sin in your own life and in the world?

Thank God that he has taken away your heart of stone and given a heart of flesh. Ask him to keep it soft.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the idols in your heart.
- Ask him to give you a heart that grieves over sin.
- Thank him that he sees all that you do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 67

"My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever."

PSALM 73:26

DAY 467 · WEEK 67

Ezekiel 12:1-14:23

The rebellious house; false prophets

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 12:1-14:23. Ezekiel packs his bags to dramatize exile, condemns false prophets who say “Peace,” and exposes idols in the heart. Read especially 14:1-11 and 14:12-23.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The exiles in Babylon were hearing prophets who told them that the fall of Jerusalem was far off, or would not happen. Ezekiel’s sign-acts and words in these chapters answer them. Chapter 12 shows him leaving his house like an exile. Chapter 13 attacks false prophets and prophetesses. Chapter 14 deals with elders who come to inquire of the LORD while hiding idols in their hearts.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Son of man, you dwell in the midst of a rebellious house, who have eyes to see, but see not, who have ears to hear, but hear not” (12:2).
2. “None of my words will be delayed any longer, but the word that I speak will be performed” (12:28).
3. “Woe to the foolish prophets who follow their own spirit, and have seen nothing!” (13:3).
4. “They have misled my people, saying, Peace, when there is no peace, and because, when the people build a wall, these prophets smear it with whitewash” (13:10).
5. “Son of man, these men have taken their idols into their hearts, and set the stumbling block of their iniquity before their faces” (14:3).

6. “Repent and turn away from your idols, and turn away your faces from all your abominations” (14:6).

7. “Even if these three men, Noah, Daniel, and Job, were in it, they would deliver but their own lives by their righteousness” (14:14).

8. “I have not done without cause all that I have done in it, declares the Lord GOD” (14:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Ezekiel’s sign-act in chapter 12 is an exile’s departure. He packs his baggage in daylight, digs through a wall in the evening, covers his face, and goes out in the dark. It dramatizes what will happen to the prince in Jerusalem: Zedekiah will try to flee through a hole in the wall, and be caught. The people ask, “The vision that he sees is for many days from now.” God says, “None of my words will be delayed any longer.” The false comfort of delay is removed.

Chapter 13 attacks those who profit from false hope. The prophets “prophesy from their own hearts.” They are like jackals in the ruins, not repairing the breach in the wall. They are like those who whitewash a flimsy wall. When the storm comes, it falls. A wall looks solid but cannot stand. The false prophetesses use magic bands to ensnare souls. The common thread is that they lead God’s people away from reality.

Chapter 14 is one of the most searching passages in the Bible. Elders come to Ezekiel to inquire of the LORD. God says that they have idols in their hearts. They are outwardly respectable and inwardly corrupted. “Should I be consulted by them at all?” God will answer such a person himself in a way that will frighten him. The call is to repent. God does not want a religious show but a turned heart.

The chapter ends with four judgments: famine, wild beasts, sword, and plague. Even if Noah, Daniel, and Job were there, they would save only themselves. Righteousness is personal. No one can be saved by the faith of another. Yet there will be survivors, and when they arrive in Babylon, the exiles will see how wicked they were and be comforted. The last line gives God’s reason: “You shall know that I have not done without cause all that I have done.” The judgment is just.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus warned against false prophets in sheep’s clothing (Matthew 7:15) and said, “You are like whitewashed tombs” (Matthew 23:27). 1 John 5:21 says, “Little children, keep yourselves from idols.” Colossians 3:5 says that covetousness is idolatry. 2 Timothy 4:3-4 speaks of teachers who say what itching ears want to hear. James 4:8 says, “Cleanse your hands, you sinners, and purify your hearts.” Romans 14:12: “Each of us will give an account of himself to God.”

STEP 6

Application

Ask: What idol have I taken into my heart? Name it honestly before God.

Are there places in your life where you whitewash a weak wall: appearances, excuses, or comfortable lies?

Be wary of comfort that does not come from the word of God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to search your heart and show you your idols.
- Repent and turn from them in your own words.
- Ask him to keep you from false teachers.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 67

"My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever."

PSALM 73:26

DAY 468 · WEEK 67

Ezekiel 15:1-17:24

The vine; the unfaithful wife; the two eagles

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 59 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 15:1-17:24. Three parables: a useless vine, an unfaithful wife, and two eagles with a cedar. Read the second one, in chapter 16, carefully. It is among the most intense chapters in the Bible, and it ends with an everlasting covenant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ezekiel uses a series of images to explain Jerusalem's history. Chapter 15 compares Israel to the wood of a vine, which is good for nothing but fire. Chapter 16 tells the story of a foundling girl who was rescued by God, adorned, married, and then unfaithful. Chapter 17 uses two eagles and a cedar shoot to describe Zedekiah's rebellion against Babylon. They explain why Jerusalem is falling and prepare for the promise of restoration.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "How does the wood of the vine surpass any wood, the vine branch that is among the trees of the forest?" (15:2).
2. "On the day you were born your navel cord was not cut... No eye pitied you... but you were cast out on the open field" (16:4-5).
3. "I passed by you and saw you wallowing in your blood, and I said to you in your blood, Live!" (16:6).
4. "I spread the corner of my garment over you and covered your nakedness; I made my vow to you and entered into a covenant with you, declares the Lord GOD, and you became mine" (16:8).
5. "But you trusted in your beauty and played the whore because of your renown" (16:15).

6. “Yet I will remember my covenant with you in the days of your youth, and I will establish for you an everlasting covenant” (16:60).
7. “I will take a sprig from the lofty top of the cedar and will plant it” (17:22).
8. “And all the trees of the field shall know that I am the LORD; I bring low the high tree, and make high the low tree” (17:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The vine in chapter 15 is a short parable with a clear point. A vine is valuable for its fruit. Its wood is useless for building. A vine that does not bear fruit is only for fire. Jerusalem’s status as God’s vine does not protect her. If she does not bear fruit, she is fuel. The people had grown proud of their position. Ezekiel says that position without fruit is worthless.

The story of chapter 16 is a long and unsettling picture. A baby is abandoned in a field, unwashed, uncut, with no one to pity her. God passes by and says, “Live!” He raises her, and when she is grown, he enters into a covenant with her, clothes her in fine linen and jewelry, and makes her queen. This is the history of Israel from Abraham, a rescued foundling. She is adopted and adorned. Then she trusts in her beauty and uses her gifts to play the prostitute with every passerby: Egypt, Assyria, Babylon. She even sacrifices her children. She is worse than Sodom.

The chapter is hard to read, and it is meant to be. It shows the ugliness of idolatry from God’s point of view: not just rule-breaking but betrayal of love. Everything Israel had was a gift, and she used it against the giver.

Yet the end of the chapter is astonishing. “Yet I will remember my covenant with you in the days of your youth, and I will establish for you an everlasting covenant.” God will make atonement for her. “That you may remember and be confounded, and never open your mouth again because of your shame, when I atone for you for all that you have done.” Grace is the final word.

Chapter 17 ends with another promise: God himself will take a sprig from the top of the cedar and plant it on a high mountain, where it becomes a noble cedar. It is a messianic promise, the Davidic king who will shelter all birds.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I am the true vine” (John 15:1-6) and warned that branches that bear no fruit are thrown into the fire. Ephesians 5:25-27 says Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her to present her to himself in splendor. Romans 5:8 says that God showed his love for us in

that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us. Mark 4:30-32 describes the kingdom as a mustard seed that becomes a tree where birds find shelter. Hebrews 13:20 speaks of the blood of the eternal covenant.

STEP 6

Application

Remember where you came from: you were like the abandoned baby in the field, and God said “Live!”

Think about the gifts God has given you. Are you using them for him?

Receive the promise of an everlasting covenant, and rest in the atonement made for you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for finding you cast out, and telling you to live.

Thank him for covering you and entering into covenant.

Confess where you have been unfaithful.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 67

“My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever.”

PSALM 73:26

DAY 469 · WEEK 67

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 73:26 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever."

PSALM 73:26

REST

Meditation

This verse is the climax of Psalm 73, written by a man who almost lost his faith. After all his struggles, he comes to this confession.

"My flesh and my heart may fail." He is honest about his limits. Flesh is the body, with its weakness and mortality. Heart is the inner life, with its feelings and strength. Both can fail. The prosperous wicked looked so strong, and the psalmist felt so weak. But he does not say that his flesh and heart will not fail. They may. He admits it.

"But God is the strength of my heart." The word for strength can mean rock. God is the rock of my heart. When all else gives way, he is solid. Notice the difference: it is not that I am strong, but that God is my strength. The psalmist did not discover an inner reserve of courage. He discovered that God holds him up.

“And my portion forever.” A portion was a share of inheritance. In the land of Israel, each family received a portion. The Levites received none, because the LORD was their portion. The psalmist makes this his own. He says that God is his inheritance. Everything else may be lost, but God is his share. And it is forever, beyond death.

This is a verse for the weak and the weary. It does not ask you to be strong. It invites you to rest your weakness on the one who is. Say this verse when your body is tired, when your heart is troubled, or when you fear the future. God is the strength of your heart, and he is your portion forever.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you prayed two psalms of crisis: Psalm 73, where Asaph nearly stumbled when he saw the prosperity of the wicked until he entered God’s presence and declared, “Whom have I in heaven but you?”, and Psalm 77, where God’s footprints were unseen but his way was holy. You walked through the first part of Ezekiel. You saw the prophet act out the siege of Jerusalem, and watched the idolatry in the temple in his vision. You watched the glory of the LORD depart from the temple in reluctant stages, and heard the promise of a heart of flesh and a new spirit. You read God’s warnings against false prophets who whitewash a weak wall, and against idols in the heart. And you read the parables of the useless vine, the faithless wife, and the cedar sprig, which ended with an everlasting covenant. The week taught that God takes sin seriously, that his glory is not confined to a building, and that he promises a new heart.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Asaph’s view changed when he entered God’s presence. What would it look like to bring a question or envy into God’s presence this week, and wait?

Ezekiel saw the glory of God leave the temple, and then promised a heart of flesh. What hardness in your heart do you most need God to soften?

God says “Live!” to the abandoned child in chapter 16. How does this image of grace shape how you understand your own story?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what is failing in you, and tell him he is the strength of your heart.

Thank him for the new heart he has promised.

Rest in him.

DAY 470 · WEEK 68

Psalm 122

I was glad when they said, "Let us go to the house of the LORD"

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 122. It is a Song of Ascents of David, a joyful song for a pilgrim arriving in Jerusalem. Read it as a hope for the exiles, who longed to go up again.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 122 is the third of the Songs of Ascents you have started reading. Pilgrims sang these as they climbed to Jerusalem for the festivals. For exiles in Babylon, it was a memory and a promise: someday they would stand in those gates again. The psalm is about three things: the joy of going to the house of the LORD, the city as a place of unity and justice, and the prayer for its peace.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I was glad when they said to me, Let us go to the house of the LORD!" (v. 1).
2. "Our feet have been standing within your gates, O Jerusalem!" (v. 2).
3. "Jerusalem, built as a city that is bound firmly together" (v. 3).
4. "To which the tribes go up, the tribes of the LORD, as was decreed for Israel, to give thanks to the name of the LORD" (v. 4).
5. "There thrones for judgment were set, the thrones of the house of David" (v. 5).
6. "Pray for the peace of Jerusalem! May they be secure who love you!" (v. 6).
7. "Peace be within your walls and security within your towers!" (v. 7).
8. "For the sake of the house of the LORD our God, I will seek your good" (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with gladness. The psalmist was glad when others said, “Let us go.” It is a statement about the joy of communal worship. We do not usually travel alone to God’s house. Someone invites us, and we go together. And he remembers the first words: “Let us go.” There is something about being invited into worship that stirs the heart.

The second verse is the arrival. “Our feet have been standing within your gates.” The journey is over, and they are in the city. For the exiles, this verse must have been bittersweet. They had no gates to stand in. But they could dream of it, and the psalm gave them words.

Jerusalem is described as a city “bound firmly together,” a place of unity. The tribes go up together to give thanks, and justice is administered there. The city is the center of the covenant community. It is a picture of what God’s people are meant to be: united, worshiping, and just.

The psalm ends with a prayer for peace. “Pray for the peace of Jerusalem!” There is a word play on the city’s name, which means “foundation of peace.” The peace prayed for is shalom, wholeness and well-being, within the walls and in the towers. And the motive is love: “For the sake of my brothers and companions, I will say, Peace be within you!” And the highest reason: “For the sake of the house of the LORD our God, I will seek your good.”

For Christians, Jerusalem is not just a geographic place. The church is described as the new Jerusalem, the “Jerusalem above.” This psalm teaches us to love the gathered people of God, to take joy in worship, and to pray for the church’s peace and unity.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 12:22-24 says that believers have come to Mount Zion, “the heavenly Jerusalem.” Galatians 4:26 speaks of “the Jerusalem above” as our mother. Revelation 21:2 describes the new Jerusalem coming down from heaven like a bride. Hebrews 10:24-25 calls us not to neglect meeting together. Ephesians 4:3 urges us to maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace. John 14:27: “Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you.”

STEP 6

Application

Be glad in going to church this week. Pray ahead of time for those you will meet.

Pray for the peace and unity of your own church by name, as the psalm prays for Jerusalem.

Invite someone to worship with you, as in verse 1: “Let us go to the house of the LORD.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you are glad to go to his house.
- Ask him to bind his church together in peace.
- Pray for your own church by name.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 68

"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."

EZEKIEL 18:32

DAY 471 · WEEK 68

Psalm 123; Psalm 126

Eyes on the LORD; restored fortunes

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 123 and Psalm 126. Psalm 123 lifts the eyes to God in humble need. Psalm 126 celebrates the return from captivity and then prays for more. Read them together as songs of people who depend completely on God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These are two more Songs of Ascents. Psalm 123 is a short, almost whispered prayer of a people who have been treated with contempt. Psalm 126 is a classic song of return: it looks back on the joy of release from exile and forward to the harvest still to come. In the context of this unit, they offer a glimpse of what lies on the far side of the exile.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “To you I lift up my eyes, O you who are enthroned in the heavens!” (123:1).
2. “Behold, as the eyes of servants look to the hand of their master… so our eyes look to the LORD our God, till he has mercy upon us” (123:2).
3. “Have mercy upon us, O LORD, have mercy upon us, for we have had more than enough of contempt” (123:3).
4. “When the LORD restored the fortunes of Zion, we were like those who dream” (126:1).
5. “Then our mouth was filled with laughter, and our tongue with shouts of joy” (126:2).
6. “The LORD has done great things for us; we are glad” (126:3).
7. “Restore our fortunes, O LORD, like streams in the Negeb!” (126:4).
8. “Those who sow in tears shall reap with shouts of joy! He who goes out weeping, bearing the seed for sowing, shall come home with shouts of joy, bringing his sheaves

with him" (126:5-6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 123 is a prayer of upward gaze. The psalmist lifts his eyes to the one "enthroned in the heavens." He compares his people to servants who watch their master's hand, waiting for a signal. The servant does not make demands. He watches, ready, depending on the master for provision. So Israel's eyes are on the LORD until he shows mercy. The reason is contempt: "We have had more than enough of contempt... the scorn of those who are at ease." It is the cry of a people who have been mocked and who have only one place to look.

There is humility here that is rare. The servant does not need to understand. He only needs to see the hand. In a world where we are encouraged to look to ourselves, this psalm teaches us to look to God.

Psalm 126 begins with a memory of a joy so great that it seemed like a dream. "When the LORD restored the fortunes of Zion, we were like those who dream." The return from Babylon was too good to be true. The nations noticed: "The LORD has done great things for them." And they said so too. Laughter and shouting filled the people.

But then, in verse 4, the psalm becomes a prayer: "Restore our fortunes, O LORD, like streams in the Negeb." The Negeb is a dry desert region where streams flow only after the rains, suddenly and abundantly. The people have returned, but the restoration is incomplete. They ask for more. And the psalm ends with a great promise: "Those who sow in tears shall reap with shouts of joy!" The sower weeps because seed is precious in a famine. Yet he goes out and sows. And he will come home carrying sheaves. The tears are not wasted. Sowing in tears is an act of faith that the harvest will come.

For exiles reading these psalms from afar, they are both a hope and a pattern: depend on God, and remember that sowing in sorrow will end in joy.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, "Blessed are you who weep now, for you shall laugh" (Luke 6:21), and "Your sorrow will turn into joy" (John 16:20). 2 Corinthians 9:6 says whoever sows bountifully will reap bountifully. Galatians 6:9 says, "Let us not grow weary of doing good, for in due season we will reap." Hebrews 12:2 says that Jesus, for the joy set before him, endured the cross. Revelation 7:17 promises that God will wipe away every tear.

STEP 6

Application

Choose to look to God today as the servant looks to the master's hand. Wait for his direction.

Think of something you have been "sowing in tears," such as a hard prayer, a difficult relationship, or a sacrificial act. Continue.

Remember a joy that felt like a dream, and thank God for it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Lift your eyes to God as a servant looks to his master.
- Ask him to show mercy to you.
- Thank him for restoring fortunes.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 68

"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."

EZEKIEL 18:32

DAY 472 · WEEK 68

Ezekiel 18:1-20:49

Individual responsibility; elegy for Israel's princes [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 104 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 18:1-20:49. This is a survey day. Chapter 18 is the great chapter on individual responsibility and God's desire for repentance. Chapter 19 is a lament for Israel's princes. Chapter 20 is another review of Israel's history. Focus on chapter 18.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The exiles had a proverb: "The fathers have eaten sour grapes, and the children's teeth are set on edge." They were blaming their ancestors for the exile and saying that nothing they did could change it. God answers through Ezekiel with one of the most important chapters on personal responsibility and repentance. Chapters 19 and 20 then give two more views of Israel's story: laments for her kings and another review of her history of rebellion.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "What do you mean by repeating this proverb... The fathers have eaten sour grapes, and the children's teeth are set on edge?" (18:2).
2. "Behold, all souls are mine; the soul of the father as well as the soul of the son is mine: the soul who sins shall die" (18:4).
3. "If a man is righteous and does what is just and right... he shall surely live, declares the Lord GOD" (18:5, 9).
4. "Have I any pleasure in the death of the wicked, declares the Lord GOD, and not rather that he should turn from his way and live?" (18:23).
5. "Yet you say, The way of the Lord is not just. Hear now, O house of Israel: Is my way not just?" (18:25).

6. “Repent and turn from all your transgressions, lest iniquity be your ruin” (18:30).
7. “Make yourselves a new heart and a new spirit! Why will you die, O house of Israel?” (18:31).
8. “For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live” (18:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The proverb about sour grapes expresses fatalism. The exiles felt trapped by their ancestors’ sins. God rejects the proverb and states a principle: each person is accountable for their own sin. “The soul who sins shall die.” The chapter gives three cases: a righteous father who lives, his violent son who dies, and his righteous grandson who lives. The grandson does not die for the father’s sins. Each stands on his own.

The point is not that God abandoned the principle of corporate solidarity, which appears elsewhere. It is that no one can blame the past to avoid responsibility. And it is also a word of hope: a wicked person who turns from sin will live. “None of the transgressions that he has committed shall be remembered against him.” Repentance is real. The way is open.

The question God asks in verse 23 is among the most beautiful in the Bible: “Have I any pleasure in the death of the wicked… and not rather that he should turn from his way and live?” God does not enjoy judgment. His desire is that people turn and live. The exiles complain that “the way of the Lord is not just,” but God replies that his ways are just. It is their ways that are unjust.

The chapter ends with an invitation: “Make yourselves a new heart and a new spirit!” It sounds like a command to do the impossible, since later chapters will promise that God himself gives the new heart (36:26). Both are true. We are commanded to turn, and God enables the turning. “For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone; so turn, and live.” The gospel is already audible.

Chapter 19 is a dirge about Judah’s last kings, as lion cubs trapped and a vine uprooted. Chapter 20 reviews God’s mercy and Israel’s rebellion from Egypt, closing with a promise to gather them and be sanctified in them.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Peter 3:9 says that the Lord is “not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance.” 1 Timothy 2:4 says he desires all people to be saved. Romans 14:12 says that each of us will give an account of himself to God. John 9:2-3 shows Jesus rejecting the idea

that suffering always traces to a particular person's sin. Acts 3:19 calls us to repent. Romans 6:23: "The wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life."

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you are using someone else's sin or your past as an excuse. Take responsibility, and then turn to God.

Write down Ezekiel 18:32 and carry it with you as a reminder of God's heart.

Offer the invitation of this chapter to someone who feels trapped: "Turn, and live."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you blame others or your past.
- Turn from a specific transgression and tell him so.
- Thank him that he has no pleasure in anyone's death.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 68

"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."

EZEKIEL 18:32

DAY 473 · WEEK 68

Ezekiel 21:1-24:27

The sword of judgment; Ezekiel's wife dies, sign act

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 117 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 21:1-24:27. A sword is drawn against Jerusalem, a rusty pot boils on a fire, and Ezekiel's wife dies at God's command. Read chapter 24 slowly. It is one of the saddest passages in the prophets.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is now 588 BC, and the siege of Jerusalem is beginning. On the very day, Ezekiel, far away in Babylon, is told to write down the date. The rest of this section describes the sword of the LORD and the sins of the city. Chapter 24 ends the first main part of the book. God tells Ezekiel that his wife will die, and he is not to mourn publicly. His grief becomes a sign to the exiles of what will happen to them when the temple falls.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, I am against you, and will draw my sword from its sheath" (21:3).
2. "A sword, a sword is sharpened and also polished" (21:9).
3. "I will make you a ruin, ruin, ruin… until he comes, the one to whom the judgment belongs, and I will give it to him" (21:27).
4. "And I sought for a man among them who should build up the wall and stand in the breach before me for the land, that I should not destroy it, but I found none" (22:30).
5. "Son of man, there were two women, the daughters of one mother" (23:2).
6. "Son of man, write down the name of this day, this very day. The king of Babylon has laid siege to Jerusalem this very day" (24:2).

7. “Behold, I am about to take the delight of your eyes away from you at a stroke; yet you shall not mourn or weep” (24:16).

8. “So I spoke to the people in the morning, and at evening my wife died” (24:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 21 shows the sword of the LORD, polished for slaughter. The king of Babylon stands at a fork in the road and uses divination to decide whether to attack Jerusalem or Rabbah. God directs the lot toward Jerusalem. It is a reminder that even pagan decisions serve God’s purpose. And the last line hints at hope: “until he comes, the one to whom the judgment belongs.” This is a messianic hint. The rightful king will come.

Chapter 22 lists the sins of the city: bloodshed, idolatry, contempt for parents, extortion from the sojourner, oppression of the fatherless and widow, profaning the Sabbath, adultery, bribery. The leaders are blamed: priests, princes, prophets, and people. Then comes the saddest verse: “I sought for a man among them who should build up the wall and stand in the breach before me for the land, that I should not destroy it, but I found none.” God was looking for an intercessor, someone like Moses. There was no one. The absence of a mediator is a deep need.

Chapter 23 tells the story of two sisters, Oholah (Samaria) and Oholibah (Jerusalem), who gave themselves to foreign lovers. It is a harsh allegory of political and religious unfaithfulness.

Chapter 24 begins with a boiling pot. The rusty pot, full of choice pieces of meat, is set on a fire until it is empty and burned clean. It shows Jerusalem under siege, with her bloodguilt cooked in her. Then comes the personal blow. God tells Ezekiel that his wife, “the delight of your eyes,” will die. He is told not to mourn publicly. The next day, he does as commanded. When the people ask why, he says that when the temple, “the delight of your eyes,” is taken, they too will be struck silent. His grief was a sign.

We should not skip past the cost to Ezekiel. He is a person with real feelings, who loves his wife. Prophetic ministry is not detached. It can mean personal loss. And in his silence, we hear the weight of the judgment.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Timothy 2:5 says, “There is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus.” Hebrews 7:25 says he always lives to make intercession. Isaiah 59:16 says God saw that there was no one to intercede, and his own arm brought salvation. Jesus stood in the breach on the

cross. Romans 12:15 says to weep with those who weep. 1 Thessalonians 4:13 says we do not grieve as those who have no hope.

STEP 6

Application

Be someone who stands in the breach for others. Pray earnestly for a specific person, family, or situation.

Think about the cost to those who serve God faithfully, and pray for pastors and missionaries who have suffered loss.

Thank Jesus, the one mediator, who stood in the breach for you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for standing in the breach for you.
- Pray for someone you can stand in the breach for.
- Ask him to keep you from indifference.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 68

"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."

EZEKIEL 18:32

DAY 474 · WEEK 68

Ezekiel 25:1-28:26

Oracles against the nations [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 25:1-28:26. This is a survey day. These are oracles against Ammon, Moab, Edom, Philistia, and above all Tyre and its king. Look for the reasons given, and for one of the clearest echoes of the story of the fall of Satan.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the fall of Jerusalem is announced, Ezekiel turns to the nations around Judah. They had gloated over Jerusalem's fall. The long oracle against Tyre in chapters 26 to 28 is the central part. Tyre was a wealthy commercial city on the Phoenician coast and the center of Mediterranean trade. Its king is addressed with language that goes beyond any human ruler.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Because you said, Aha! over my sanctuary when it was profaned... I will give you to the people of the East" (25:3-4).
2. "Behold, I am against you, O Tyre, and will bring up many nations against you, as the sea brings up its waves" (26:3).
3. "You were the signet of perfection, full of wisdom and perfect in beauty" (28:12).
4. "You were in Eden, the garden of God" (28:13).
5. "You were an anointed guardian cherub. I placed you; you were on the holy mountain of God" (28:14).
6. "You were blameless in your ways from the day you were created, till unrighteousness was found in you" (28:15).

7. “Your heart was proud because of your beauty; you corrupted your wisdom for the sake of your splendor” (28:17).

8. “Thus says the Lord GOD: When I gather the house of Israel from the peoples among whom they are scattered… they shall dwell securely in it” (28:25-26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first oracles are brief. Ammon, Moab, Edom, and Philistia are each condemned because they mocked or took vengeance on Judah. “Because you said Aha!” God takes personally what is done to his people. The vindication of his name is the repeated purpose: “Then they will know that I am the LORD.”

Tyre’s sin is arrogance. It rejoiced in Jerusalem’s downfall because it expected to profit from the loss of a trade rival. God promises the city’s destruction, with many nations coming against it like waves. Nebuchadnezzar besieged the mainland city for thirteen years, and Alexander the Great later destroyed the island fortress. Chapter 27 is a magnificent lament over Tyre as a great merchant ship laden with goods from all the world, which sinks.

Chapter 28 addresses the prince of Tyre first as a man who said, “I am a god, I sit in the seat of the gods.” He is mocked: “You are indeed wiser than Daniel; no secret is hidden from you.” Then, in verse 12, there is a lament for the “king of Tyre,” and the language soars beyond any human king. He was in Eden. He was an anointed guardian cherub on the holy mountain of God. He was blameless until iniquity was found in him. He was cast out in pride. Many readers, from early church writers on, see in this an echo of the fall of Satan, the power behind pride. Whether or not the language refers directly to him, the pattern is the same as in Isaiah 14: pride goes before a fall.

The chapter ends with a promise to Israel. God will gather his people, and they will dwell in security, with no more pricking briers or painful thorns among their neighbors. The enemies who mocked will be removed, and God’s holiness will be shown.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 10:18: Jesus said, “I saw Satan fall like lightning from heaven.” 1 Timothy 3:6 warns that a recent convert may fall into the condemnation of the devil through conceit. Revelation 18 laments the fall of Babylon in terms like Ezekiel 27. Proverbs 16:18: “Pride goes before destruction.” James 4:6: “God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble.” Philippians 2:5-8 shows Christ, who humbled himself, the opposite of the king of Tyre.

STEP 6

Application

Examine where pride or self-sufficiency has crept in. Humble yourself before God.

Do not rejoice when others fall. Ask God to guard your heart from the spirit of “Aha!”

Look to Jesus, who did not count equality with God something to be grasped, but humbled himself.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to guard you from pride in gifts and wealth.

Ask him to keep you from rejoicing in another’s downfall.

Thank him for giving grace to the humble.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 68

“For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live.”

EZEKIEL 18:32

DAY 475 · WEEK 68

Ezekiel 29:1-32:32

Oracles against Egypt [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 100 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 29:1-32:32. This is a survey day. These chapters are oracles against Egypt and its Pharaoh, including the famous images of the crocodile in the Nile and the great tree cut down. Read for the theme: pride before God is brought low.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ezekiel's seven oracles against Egypt fill these chapters. Judah had often looked to Egypt for help against Babylon, and Egypt had often failed her. The oracles say that God will humble Egypt, and that she will never again be a source of false security for Israel. They are dated to the siege of Jerusalem and afterward, between 587 and 571 BC.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, I am against you, Pharaoh king of Egypt, the great dragon that lies in the midst of his streams, that says, My Nile is my own; I made it for myself" (29:3).
2. "You have been a staff of reed to the house of Israel" (29:6).
3. "And it shall be the most lowly of the kingdoms, and never again exalt itself above the nations" (29:15).
4. "And they will know that I am the LORD" (29:21, one of many repetitions).
5. "Wail, Alas for the day!" (30:2).
6. "Whom are you like in your greatness? Behold, Assyria was a cedar in Lebanon" (31:2-3).
7. "Therefore thus says the Lord GOD: Because it towered high… I will give it into the hand of a mighty one among the nations" (31:10-11).
8. "They lie among the uncircumcised, with those who are slain by the sword" (32:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Egypt is addressed as a great crocodile in the Nile who claims, “My Nile is my own; I made it for myself.” It is a claim of self-creation, the essence of pride. God will pull him out with hooks in his jaws and leave him in the desert. Egypt had been a “staff of reed” to Israel. When Judah leaned on it, it splintered and pierced their hand. The lesson is that trusting in political alliances rather than in God is a broken support.

The oracles describe Egypt’s fall in various images: a land laid waste, a sword coming on Cush and Put, a Pharaoh with a broken arm. God will scatter the Egyptians and bring them back after forty years, but as a lowly kingdom that never again rules. The reason is not only for judgment, but “then they will know that I am the LORD.”

Chapter 31 compares Pharaoh to the great cedar of Lebanon, a tree that towered above all others in the garden of God. All the birds nested in its boughs. But it was proud, and God cut it down. The lesson is for Egypt by comparing it to Assyria, which had been another great tree and was cut down. If Assyria fell, so will Egypt.

Chapter 32 contains two laments over Pharaoh and a picture of his descent to Sheol, among the uncircumcised and the slain, in the company of Assyria, Elam, and others. The nations are brought down to the pit, one after another. It is a solemn picture of the equality of death. All who exalt themselves will lie among the dead.

The main message in all of these oracles is simple: God rules over the nations. No power, however great, is beyond his hand. It is a comfort for those who feel crushed by empires, and a warning for those who think they are secure.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 12:21-23 shows Herod struck down for accepting worship as a god. Isaiah 31:1 warns against going down to Egypt for help. Luke 1:52: “He has brought down the mighty from their thrones and exalted those of humble estate.” Psalm 20:7: “Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God.” Matthew 2:13-15 shows God calling his Son out of Egypt.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a “staff of reed” you have leaned on: a person, a plan, or a resource that has broken. Place your weight on God instead.

Pray for nations experiencing the pride of power and for those who suffer under it.

Remember that God rules history, and that no power is permanent.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as ruler over every nation.
- Ask him to forgive where you lean on reed staffs.
- Tell him whom you trust, and give it to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 68

"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."

EZEKIEL 18:32

DAY 476 · WEEK 68

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Ezekiel 18:32 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."

EZEKIEL 18:32

REST

Meditation

This verse is both a word of judgment and a word of love. It stands at the end of the chapter about individual responsibility, and it is God's own explanation of why he calls people to repentance.

"I have no pleasure in the death of anyone." This is a statement about God's heart. Many people think of God as someone who is eager to punish. This verse says the opposite. When someone dies in sin, God takes no delight in it. Judgment is real, and God carries it out. But it is his "strange work," as Isaiah calls it. It is not his joy.

"Declares the Lord GOD." The title used here, Adonai Yahweh, is the strongest possible way to say that the Master and covenant God is speaking. The statement is not a casual opinion. It is a sworn declaration.

“So turn, and live.” This is the invitation. The command to turn is a command to repent, to change direction. The result is life. Notice the simplicity: turn, and live. The exiles had been saying that their situation was hopeless. God says the way is open. Turn.

The Christian reads this verse in light of the cross. God’s desire for people to live is shown in the fact that he sent his Son. “God so loved the world that he gave his only Son.” In Christ, the call to turn is also a call to come to the one who has taken the death we deserved.

Say this verse for yourself when you are tempted to think that God is only waiting to condemn you. Say it for others when you pray for them. God does not want anyone to die. Turn, and live.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you prayed three Songs of Ascents: Psalm 122, the joy of going up to the house of the LORD, and Psalms 123 and 126, the servant’s eyes on his master and the promise that those who sow in tears will reap with shouts of joy. You read Ezekiel 18, in which God rejects the proverb about sour grapes, declares that each soul is accountable, and says that he has no pleasure in the death of anyone. You read about the sword drawn against Jerusalem, God’s search for someone to stand in the breach, and the death of Ezekiel’s wife as a sign of the grief to come. You surveyed the oracles against the nations: Ammon, Moab, Edom, Philistia, Tyre and its proud king, and Egypt with its crocodile and fallen cedar. The week taught that each person is responsible before God, that he delights in repentance, and that pride before him is brought low.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Ezekiel 18 insists that no one can blame the past for their present. Is there an area where you have been tempted to say, “The fathers have eaten sour grapes”?

God looked for someone to stand in the breach and found none. Who is someone you could stand in the breach for through prayer this week?

Psalm 126 says that those who sow in tears will reap with shouts of joy. What is something you are sowing in tears right now, and what would it look like to trust the harvest?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he has no pleasure in anyone's death.

Thank him for the cross where he stood in the breach for you.

Turn to him and live.

DAY 477 · WEEK 69

Psalm 128; Psalm 129

Blessed is everyone who fears the LORD

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 128 and Psalm 129. These are Songs of Ascents. Psalm 128 describes the blessing of a family that fears the LORD. Psalm 129 remembers a long history of affliction and survival. Read them as the two sides of pilgrim life: peace at home, and enemies on the road.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These two psalms are placed side by side in the Songs of Ascents. Psalm 128 is a wisdom psalm that was likely sung at weddings and family festivals. Psalm 129 recalls how Israel had been attacked "from my youth" yet never overcome. Together they speak to people who had been through exile and survived: God blesses the faithful, and he preserves his people through persecution.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed is everyone who fears the LORD, who walks in his ways!" (128:1).
2. "You shall eat the fruit of the labor of your hands; you shall be blessed, and it shall be well with you" (128:2).
3. "Your wife will be like a fruitful vine within your house; your children will be like olive shoots around your table" (128:3).
4. "Behold, thus shall the man be blessed who fears the LORD" (128:4).
5. "The LORD bless you from Zion! May you see the prosperity of Jerusalem all the days of your life!" (128:5).
6. "Greatly have they afflicted me from my youth" (129:1).

7. “Yet they have not prevailed against me” (129:2).

8. “The LORD is righteous; he has cut the cords of the wicked” (129:4).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 128 is a short portrait of a blessed life. The blessing is not described in terms of wealth or power, but of ordinary things: work that is fruitful, a family that is flourishing, and a table with children around it. The source is “the fear of the LORD,” a reverent trust that shapes daily life. The man who walks in God’s ways finds that his labor is blessed, and his home is a place of joy.

The picture of the fruitful vine and olive shoots is of life and growth. A vine in a home was a sign of abundance. Olive shoots, around a table, were a sign of vitality. The psalm does not promise that every godly person will have a large family or comfortable job. It describes the shape of God’s blessing in the ordinary life of his people, and it places that blessing within the larger blessing of Zion: “May you see the prosperity of Jerusalem all the days of your life! May you see your children’s children!” Personal and communal blessing go together.

Psalm 129 is a contrast. “Greatly have they afflicted me from my youth.” Israel’s history from Egypt on has been one of oppression. “Yet they have not prevailed against me.” It is a statement of survival. Plowmen plowed on my back, and made long their furrows. But the LORD is righteous. He cut the cords of the wicked. And the psalm closes with a curse on those who hate Zion: let them be like grass on the housetops, which withers before it grows, and which no reaper can use. Even in affliction, the people were not destroyed.

Together, these psalms speak to the situation of the exiles. They had survived. They were returning home to rebuild homes and families. The God who had kept them through persecution would bless them in ordinary life.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 6:33 says to seek first the kingdom of God. Ephesians 5:22-33 and 6:1-4 teach about the family under God. Psalm 1:2-3 describes the blessed person like a tree by the water. Romans 8:35-37 says that in all things we are more than conquerors through him who loved us. 2 Corinthians 4:8-9: “We are afflicted in every way, but not crushed.” Matthew 16:18: the gates of hell shall not prevail against the church.

STEP 6

Application

Give thanks for ordinary blessings: your work, your table, your family or friends. Name them to God.

Pray for the families in your church to flourish in the fear of the LORD.

Remember the afflictions you have survived. Say, “Yet they have not prevailed against me,” as a testimony.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to bless your work and your home.
- Thank him that he is righteous and cuts the cords of the wicked.
- Bless the families of your church.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 69

“And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.”

EZEKIEL 36:26

DAY 478 · WEEK 69

Psalm 131; Psalm 133; Psalm 134

Childlike trust; unity; blessing

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 131, Psalm 133, and Psalm 134. These are three of the shortest psalms in the Psalter, and they are full. Read each one slowly. They teach childlike trust, brotherly unity, and a blessing at night.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Three more Songs of Ascents. Psalm 131 is a psalm of David about quieting the soul. Psalm 133 celebrates the unity of God's people. Psalm 134 is the last of the group of pilgrim songs before the final two, a call to the servants of the LORD who stand by night in the house of the LORD. Together they are a tender picture of what the pilgrim learned on the journey to Zion: humility, fellowship, and worship.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, my heart is not lifted up; my eyes are not raised too high; I do not occupy myself with things too great and too marvelous for me" (131:1).
2. "But I have calmed and quieted my soul, like a weaned child with its mother; like a weaned child is my soul within me" (131:2).
3. "O Israel, hope in the LORD from this time forth and forevermore" (131:3).
4. "Behold, how good and pleasant it is when brothers dwell in unity!" (133:1).
5. "It is like the precious oil on the head, running down on the beard, on the beard of Aaron" (133:2).
6. "It is like the dew of Hermon, which falls on the mountains of Zion!" (133:3).
7. "For there the LORD has commanded the blessing, life forevermore" (133:3).

8 “Come, bless the LORD, all you servants of the LORD, who stand by night in the house of the LORD!” (134:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 131 is a prayer of humility and rest. David says, “My heart is not lifted up.” He is not proud and does not chase after impossible things. Then he describes how he has calmed his soul like a weaned child with its mother. A weaned child no longer fusses for milk but rests content in the mother’s arms, not because of what she provides, but because of who she is. This is a mature form of trust. It does not demand answers or benefits. It rests in the presence of the one who loves. The psalm ends with a call to Israel: hope in the LORD. Humility and hope go together.

Psalm 133 is a short celebration of unity. “Behold, how good and pleasant it is when brothers dwell in unity!” The image is of two kinds of abundance. The first is the anointing oil poured on Aaron’s head, running down to his beard and the collar of his robes, a picture of a lavish, fragrant blessing that covers the whole person. The second is the dew of Hermon falling on Zion. It is refreshing and life-giving. The meaning is that unity among the people of God is not something small but a rich gift from God. And “there the LORD has commanded the blessing, life forevermore.” God commands blessing where his people dwell together.

Psalm 134 is the last of the set before the closing pair. It is a call to worship, spoken to the temple servants who keep watch by night. “Come, bless the LORD.” Their work is praise. They lift up their hands in the sanctuary and bless the LORD. Then the response comes: “May the LORD bless you from Zion, he who made heaven and earth!” The blessing goes both ways.

The whole sequence of pilgrim songs ends with a night watch and a blessing. After a long journey, the people arrive, and the end of the journey is worship.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Unless you turn and become like children, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven” (Matthew 18:3). Matthew 11:28-29 invites those who are weary to take his yoke, for he is gentle and lowly in heart. John 17:20-23 shows Jesus praying that his people may be one. Ephesians 4:1-6 urges the unity of the Spirit. Colossians 3:14 says love binds everything together in perfect harmony. Revelation 7:15 shows the multitudes serving God day and night in his temple.

STEP 6

Application

Quiet your soul today. Sit for five minutes, like a weaned child with its mother, asking for nothing.

Work for unity in your church or family. Is there someone you need to forgive or reconcile with?

Pray Psalm 134 at the end of the day, as a night watch, blessing the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you want to quiet your soul like a weaned child.
- Thank him for the gift of unity among his people.
- Bless the LORD in your own words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 69

"And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh."

EZEKIEL 36:26

DAY 479 · WEEK 69

Ezekiel 33:1-35:15

The watchman renewed; the shepherds; the mountains of Israel

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 33:1-35:15. The news that Jerusalem has fallen reaches Babylon, and Ezekiel's tone changes. God renews the watchman's call and then turns on the false shepherds of Israel and promises to be the shepherd himself. Read chapter 34 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In 585 BC, a fugitive from Jerusalem arrived in Babylon with the news that the city had fallen. Ezekiel's long silence ended, and he began to speak with a new message: hope. The first part of his book was about judgment. The next is about restoration. Chapter 33 reconfirms his role as a watchman and renews God's appeal to repent. Chapter 34 is one of the greatest chapters on shepherds in the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "So you, son of man, I have made a watchman for the house of Israel" (33:7).
2. "As I live, declares the Lord GOD, I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked, but that the wicked turn from his way and live" (33:11).
3. "Behold, you are to them like one who sings lustful songs with a beautiful voice and plays well on an instrument, for they hear what you say, but they will not do it" (33:32).
4. "Woe to the shepherds of Israel who have been feeding themselves! Should not shepherds feed the sheep?" (34:2).
5. "The weak you have not strengthened, the sick you have not healed, the injured you have not bound up" (34:4).
6. "Behold, I, I myself will search for my sheep and will seek them out" (34:11).

7. “I will make them lie down, declares the Lord GOD. I will seek the lost, and I will bring back the strayed” (34:15-16).

8. “And I will set up over them one shepherd, my servant David, and he shall feed them” (34:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The news of Jerusalem’s fall releases Ezekiel from his silence. God renews his commission as watchman. The principle is repeated: if the watchman sees danger and warns, he has done his duty. If not, the blood is on his hands. And God restates the call to repentance of chapter 18: “Turn back, turn back from your evil ways, for why will you die, O house of Israel?” The people still say, “Our transgressions are upon us… how then can we live?” God’s answer is always the same: turn and live.

Verse 32 is a sober observation. The people come to hear Ezekiel as if he were an entertainer. They enjoy the sermon like a beautiful song, but do not act on it. Hearing without doing is the persistent danger.

Chapter 34 is the heart of this section. God condemns the shepherds, meaning the leaders, who have fed themselves and not the flock. They have not strengthened the weak or healed the sick or sought the lost. They have ruled with force and harshness. As a result, the sheep were scattered. God declares that he is against the shepherds. Then comes the most comforting passage: “I, I myself will search for my sheep and will seek them out.” Again and again God says what he will do: search, rescue, gather, bring, feed, make them lie down, seek the lost, bind up the injured, strengthen the weak. He will be the shepherd himself.

And then the promise: “I will set up over them one shepherd, my servant David.” God will shepherd through a king of David’s line, and make a covenant of peace, so that the wild beasts cease from the land, showers of blessing come, and the sheep live securely.

The people of God are described as “my sheep, human sheep, and I am your God.” It is among the most intimate pictures of the relationship between God and his people.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus says, “I am the good shepherd” (John 10:11), and lives out chapter 34: he seeks the lost (Luke 19:10), heals the sick, and binds up the brokenhearted. Luke 15:4-7 tells the story of the shepherd who seeks the one lost sheep. Matthew 9:36 shows him having compassion on the

crowds because they were “like sheep without a shepherd.” 1 Peter 5:1-4 calls elders to shepherd the flock willingly, as examples, and promises the unfading crown from the chief Shepherd. Hebrews 13:20 calls him the great shepherd.

STEP 6

Application

Thank Jesus for being the shepherd who searched for you.

If you have a role of leadership, ask whether you are feeding the flock or feeding yourself. Pray for pastors and church leaders.

Look for a “strayed” or “injured” sheep near you, and reach out to them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank the Good Shepherd for seeking the lost and binding up the injured.

Ask him to strengthen you where you are weak.

Pray for the shepherds you know.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 69

“And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.”

EZEKIEL 36:26

DAY 480 · WEEK 69

Ezekiel 36:1-37:28

The new heart; the valley of dry bones, Spirit and resurrection

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 63 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 36:1-37:28. These are among the most important chapters in the Old Testament. God promises to cleanse his people, give them a new heart, and put his Spirit within them. Then Ezekiel sees a valley of dry bones that come to life. Read both slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the central passage of Ezekiel's message of hope. The exiles are in despair: "Our bones are dried up, and our hope is lost." God's answer is a series of promises that go beyond a mere return to the land. He will transform the people themselves, from within. These chapters were written around 586 to 570 BC, and they are quoted in the New Testament as a description of the work of the Spirit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you shall be clean from all your uncleannesses, and from all your idols I will cleanse you" (36:25).
2. "And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh" (36:26).
3. "And I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes and be careful to obey my rules" (36:27).
4. "You shall be my people, and I will be your God" (36:28).
5. "It is not for your sake, O house of Israel, that I am about to act, but for the sake of my holy name" (36:22).

6. “Then he said to me, Son of man, can these bones live? And I answered, O Lord GOD, you know” (37:3).
7. “Behold, I will cause breath to enter you, and you shall live” (37:5).
8. “And I will put my Spirit within you, and you shall live, and I will place you in your own land. Then you shall know that I am the LORD” (37:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 36 begins with the mountains of Israel and God’s promise to restore the land. But the central part is about the people. God says that he is acting for the sake of his holy name, which had been profaned among the nations. The restoration is not because Israel deserves it. It is for God’s glory. This is the root of grace.

Then come the promises. First, cleansing: “I will sprinkle clean water on you.” Second, a new heart: “I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.” The stone heart is hard, unresponsive. The flesh heart is soft and alive. Third, the Spirit: “I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes.” This is the answer to Jeremiah’s promise of the new covenant: the law written on the heart. It is accomplished by the Spirit. The command in chapter 18, “Make yourselves a new heart,” is now fulfilled by God’s gift. The result: you will be my people, and I will be your God.

Chapter 37 gives the valley of dry bones. Ezekiel is set down in a valley full of bones, very many and very dry. God asks, “Can these bones live?” Ezekiel replies, “O Lord GOD, you know.” He is told to prophesy to the bones, and they come together, bone to bone. Sinews and flesh appear, and skin covers them. But there is no breath. He then prophesies to the breath, and the breath comes, and they stand on their feet, an exceedingly great army. It is a picture of national revival: “Our bones are dried up… we are cut off.” God says: “I will open your graves and raise you from your graves.”

The two chapters together show the means: the word of God and the Spirit of God. The same Word that prophesies and the same Spirit that gives life. Ezekiel ends with the vision of the two sticks, Judah and Israel, joined into one in the hand of the LORD, with David as king and an everlasting covenant of peace, and the sanctuary in their midst forever.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said to Nicodemus, “Unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God” (John 3:5), echoing Ezekiel 36:25-27. Titus 3:5 speaks of “the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit.” 2 Corinthians 3:3 and Romans 8:9-11 describe

the Spirit within us. Ephesians 2:1-5 says we were dead in trespasses, and God made us alive. John 5:25 says the dead will hear the voice of the Son of God and live. Romans 11:15 speaks of life from the dead.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Ezekiel 36:26, and pray it for yourself and someone you love.

Reflect on the phrase, “Can these bones live?” Where do you feel spiritually dry? Answer as Ezekiel did: “O Lord GOD, you know.”

Ask the Holy Spirit to breathe on a dead place in your life or your church.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the new heart and the Spirit he has put within you.
- Ask him to breathe life into a dry place in you.
- Ask him to cleanse you from your idols.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 69

“And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.”

EZEKIEL 36:26

DAY 481 · WEEK 69

Ezekiel 38:1-39:29

Gog and Magog, God's ultimate protection

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 38:1-39:29. A great invasion by Gog of Magog is described, and God defeats it. These chapters are hard to interpret, so read for the main point: God protects his restored people, and the nations will know he is the LORD.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the restoration promises of chapters 33 to 37, these chapters describe a final attack on God's people. Gog, the chief prince of Meshech and Tubal, comes with a coalition of nations from the far north against a people living securely in unwalled villages. The name Gog does not match any known historical king. Interpreters understand the passage in different ways: as a symbol of the final assault against God's people, as a prediction of a particular event, or as apocalyptic imagery. All agree on its main point.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Son of man, set your face toward Gog, of the land of Magog, the chief prince of Meshech and Tubal" (38:2).
2. "I will turn you about and put hooks into your jaws" (38:4).
3. "After many days you will be mustered. In the latter years you will go against the land that has been restored from war" (38:8).
4. "You will say, I will go up against the land of unwalled villages" (38:11).
5. "I will show my greatness and my holiness and make myself known in the eyes of many nations" (38:23).
6. "I will give to Gog a place for burial in Israel" (39:11).

7. “And the house of Israel shall know that I am the LORD their God, from that day forward” (39:22).

8. “And I will not hide my face anymore from them, when I pour out my Spirit upon the house of Israel” (39:29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The attack comes at a time of peace. The people are dwelling securely, apparently defenseless. Gog’s plan is to seize plunder. But God says, “I will turn you about and put hooks into your jaws.” Though Gog thinks he is acting by his own will, God is leading him out. The invasion is under God’s control, and its purpose is to display God’s greatness.

The defeat is dramatic: an earthquake, a plague, torrential rain, hailstones, fire and sulfur. The invading armies turn on each other. Their weapons are so numerous that Israel will burn them for seven years. The bodies are buried in a valley, and it takes seven months to clear the land. All of this serves the aim: “I will make myself known in the eyes of many nations. Then they will know that I am the LORD.”

The big question is how to understand this. Some interpret it as a literal battle in the end times. Others see in it a symbol of the continuing assault of the powers of this world against God’s people, which ends with God’s victory. Revelation 20:7-9 takes up the names Gog and Magog for the final rebellion of the nations after the thousand years, and says fire comes down from heaven and consumes them. In this use, Gog and Magog stand for the last desperate attack on God’s people. Whatever the details, the point is that God has the last word.

The conclusion in chapter 39 is a reminder of why the exile happened and a promise: “The nations shall know that the house of Israel went into captivity for their iniquity.” But now God will restore their fortunes, “and I will not hide my face anymore from them, when I pour out my Spirit upon the house of Israel.” The final note is the Spirit. The people who were scattered will be gathered and filled.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 20:7-10 describes the last rebellion of the nations, “Gog and Magog,” and their defeat by fire from heaven. Revelation 19:17-21 pictures the great supper of God, echoing Ezekiel 39:17-20. Joel 2:28-29 and Acts 2:16-18 speak of the pouring out of the Spirit. Romans 8:31 asks, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” Psalm 2 shows the nations raging and the LORD laughing in heaven. Matthew 16:18 says the gates of hell will not prevail.

STEP 6

Application

Whatever happens in the world, remember that God has the last word.

Do not let fear of the future overshadow your trust in the God who protects his people.

Pray that the Spirit would be poured out on your church and on the people of God worldwide.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you fear from the enemies of his people.

Thank him that he is sovereign over every nation.

Ask him for confidence in the end.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 69

"And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh."

EZEKIEL 36:26

DAY 482 · WEEK 69

Ezekiel 40:1-43:27

The new Temple vision begins [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 107 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 40:1-43:27. This is a survey day. A man with a measuring rod leads Ezekiel through a vision of a new temple, and then the glory of the LORD returns. Do not worry about the measurements. Read for the return of the glory in chapter 43.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In 573 BC, the twenty-fifth year of the exile and the fourteenth after Jerusalem's fall, Ezekiel is taken in a vision to a very high mountain in Israel. A man whose appearance is like bronze, with a measuring line in his hand, shows him a great temple complex. This is the last major vision of the book. It is a temple that has never been built in this form. Interpreters differ on its meaning, but it clearly points to a restored worship in which God's presence is central.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In visions of God he brought me to the land of Israel, and set me down on a very high mountain" (40:2).
2. "And behold, there was a man whose appearance was like bronze, with a linen cord and a measuring reed in his hand" (40:3).
3. "Son of man, look with your eyes, and hear with your ears, and set your heart upon all that I shall show you" (40:4).
4. "And behold, the glory of the God of Israel was coming from the east" (43:2).
5. "And the glory of the LORD entered the temple by the gate facing east" (43:4).
6. "Behold, the glory of the LORD filled the temple" (43:5).

7 “Son of man, this is the place of my throne and the place of the soles of my feet, where I will dwell in the midst of the people of Israel forever” (43:7).

8 “This is the law of the temple: the whole territory on the top of the mountain all around shall be most holy” (43:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The measuring of the temple takes up chapters 40 to 42, and its precision is striking. The gates, the courts, the chambers, the altar, the walls are all measured with exact detail. The temple is a perfect square, ordered and holy. The point is not the architecture but its meaning: God intends to dwell among his people in an orderly, holy relationship. The exiles lost the first temple, and this vision gave them hope that God would restore a place of worship.

The vision is a puzzle, because the dimensions do not match Solomon’s temple or the second temple that was later built. Some scholars take it as a literal temple yet to come. Others see it as a symbolic picture of God’s perfect dwelling with his people, fulfilled in Christ and the church, and consummated in the new creation. Revelation 21 describes the new Jerusalem as a cube, with no temple, “for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb.” Whatever view is held, the vision shows that God’s dwelling is not abandoned.

The climax is in chapter 43. Ezekiel had watched the glory leave the temple through the east gate in chapters 10 and 11. Now it returns through the same gate. The sound is like the sound of many waters, and the earth shines with his glory. The prophet falls on his face. “The glory of the LORD filled the temple.” This is the answer to the question that haunted the exiles: Has God left us forever? No. The glory returns.

God says, “This is the place of my throne… where I will dwell in the midst of the people of Israel forever.” And the condition is repentance: they must no more defile his holy name. The restoration includes a call to measure the pattern and be ashamed of their iniquities.

The message for all believers is that God wants to dwell among his people. The distance caused by sin has been overcome, and his glory returns.

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:14 says, “The Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory.” John 2:19-21 shows Jesus speaking of the temple of his body. 1 Corinthians 3:16-17 and Ephesians 2:19-22 call the church God’s temple, built on the foundation of the apostles and

prophets with Christ as the cornerstone. Revelation 21:3 says, “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man.” Revelation 21:22 says there is no temple in the city, for the Lord God and the Lamb are its temple.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God that his glory is not confined to a building, and that through Christ it has returned to dwell among his people.

Think of yourself as part of a temple being built. What does it mean for your holiness and your relationships in the church?

Pray for the return of God’s manifest presence in your worship.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his glory fills his house.

Thank Jesus, in whom his presence dwells among us.

Ask him to make you a holy temple.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 69

“And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.”

EZEKIEL 36:26

DAY 483 · WEEK 69

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Ezekiel 36:26 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh."

EZEKIEL 36:26

REST

Meditation

This verse is one of the clearest statements in the Old Testament of what God does in salvation. It describes an operation, not a program of self-improvement.

"I will give you a new heart." Notice who is the actor: "I." God does it. The people had been told to make themselves a new heart (Ezekiel 18:31), and they could not. Here, God promises to give one. The heart in Hebrew thought is the center of the whole person: mind, will, and emotions. Salvation reaches that deep. It is not just a change of behavior or beliefs but of the self at its center.

"And a new spirit I will put within you." The new spirit is a new disposition, a renewed inner life. In the next verse, God clarifies that this is his own Spirit: "I will put my Spirit within you." The new life is the life of the Holy Spirit in us.

“And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh.” The heart of stone is the natural condition of fallen humanity, hard, unresponsive to God, impossible to change by willpower. A stone cannot make itself soft. Only God can remove it.

“And give you a heart of flesh.” The heart of flesh is warm, living, and responsive. It can feel, love, trust, and obey. This is what happens at conversion and continues in sanctification. We are given hearts that want what God wants.

For the Christian, this verse is both an encouragement and a prayer. It encourages us because we do not have to manufacture our own spiritual life. It is a gift. And it is a prayer because we constantly need our hearts to be kept soft. Say it for yourself and for those you love who seem far from God. He is the one who gives hearts of flesh.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you prayed three groups of Songs of Ascents on family blessing, survival through affliction, childlike trust, and the beauty of unity. In Ezekiel, you heard the watchman called again and the people warned that they were listening to him like a song but not acting. You read God’s rebuke of the false shepherds and his promise to search for his sheep himself and to set up one shepherd, his servant David. You read the great promises of Ezekiel 36 and 37: cleansing water, a new heart and spirit, and the Spirit within us, and the valley of dry bones that live by the word and the breath. You read of Gog’s final assault and God’s victory, and then the vision of the new temple and the return of the glory by the east gate. The week taught that God himself will do what his people cannot, giving them hearts of flesh and his own Spirit, and returning to dwell among them.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

God says he will give a heart of flesh and put his Spirit within us. Where do you most need him to do this soft, living work in you?

God promises to shepherd his sheep himself, to seek the lost and bind up the injured. Which of these do you need the Shepherd to do for you right now?

Ezekiel asked whether dry bones can live, and answered, “O Lord GOD, you know.” What seems dead in your life or church that you can bring to God in that spirit?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to give you a new heart.

Ask him to remove the heart of stone in you.

Thank him for the Shepherd who seeks you.

DAY 484 · WEEK 70

Ezekiel 44:1-46:24

The Prince; priestly regulations; the inheritance [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 44:1-46:24. This is a survey day. These chapters describe the closed east gate, the rules for priests, the division of the land, and the worship of the prince and the people. Read for the main principle: worship in the restored temple is holy and ordered, and God's people are to approach with reverence.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This section follows the return of the glory in chapter 43. The details of the restored worship are laid out: who may enter, who may serve, how the festivals are to be kept. Many of the details are hard to match with any known period of Israel's history, and Christians have understood them in different ways. The common thread is the holiness of God and the order of worship he requires.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "This gate shall remain shut; it shall not be opened, and no one shall enter by it, for the LORD, the God of Israel, has entered by it" (44:2).
2. "No foreigner, uncircumcised in heart and flesh, of all the foreigners who are among the people of Israel, shall enter my sanctuary" (44:9).
3. "They shall teach my people the difference between the holy and the common, and show them how to distinguish between the unclean and the clean" (44:23).
4. "I am their inheritance: you shall give them no possession in Israel; I am their possession" (44:28).
5. "The land shall be for the LORD… a holy portion" (45:1).

6. “My princes shall no more oppress my people” (45:8).
7. “You shall have just balances, a just ephah, and a just bath” (45:10).
8. “The people of the land shall bow down at the entrance of that gate before the LORD on the Sabbaths and on the new moons” (46:3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The closed east gate is a symbol of God’s presence. The glory entered through it, so it stays shut. It is a picture of the finality of God’s return. Only the prince may sit in the gateway to eat bread before the LORD. The restored community is to be ordered around the holy.

The priests’ regulations are demanding. The Levites who went astray in idolatry are limited to lesser duties, while the sons of Zadok, who stayed faithful, may come near. The priests are to be careful in their clothing, grooming, and conduct. They are to teach the people the difference between the holy and the common, to judge disputes, and to keep the Sabbaths. In 44:28, there is a note that echoes Psalm 73: “I am their inheritance.” The priests have no land because God himself is their portion.

Chapter 45 sets aside a holy portion of land for the sanctuary, for the priests, and for the Levites, and a portion for the city and the prince. The prince is warned not to oppress the people. It is a vision of just leadership. “Enough, O princes of Israel! Put away violence and oppression.” He is to maintain just weights and measures. Worship and justice are joined.

Chapter 46 describes the offerings and worship of the prince and the people. The prince leads the people and enters with them: “When they go in, he shall go in.” He is among them, not above them. The chapter ends with the kitchens where the priests and people boil and bake the sacrifices.

For the Christian, the details are difficult. But we can see the principles. God is to be approached with reverence. The leader must be just and humble. Those who serve are to know God as their portion. And the people are to come together to worship. The New Testament shows that Christ has become our great high priest and our sacrifice, so these shadows find their fulfillment in him.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 8:1-6 and 9:11-14 show that Christ is the high priest of the true tent, and that his blood obtains eternal redemption. Hebrews 10:19-22 invites us to enter the holy places by the blood of Jesus. 1 Peter 2:5, 9 calls the church a holy priesthood and a royal priesthood.

Revelation 1:6 says Christ has made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father. Romans 12:1: present your bodies as a living sacrifice.

STEP 6

Application

Approach worship this week with reverence. Prepare your heart before you gather.

If you lead others, ask whether you walk among them, as the prince did, or above them.

Thank God that he is your portion and inheritance, like the Levites.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that his presence is among his people.
- Ask him to teach you to distinguish the holy from the common.
- Ask him to guard your worship.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 70

"If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up."

DANIEL 3:17-18

DAY 485 · WEEK 70

Ezekiel 47:1-48:35

The river of life; the new land, new creation anticipated

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezekiel 47:1-48:35. A river flows from the temple and turns a desert into a place of life, and the land is divided among the twelve tribes, ending with a city whose name is "The LORD Is There." Read the river carefully, and notice what it does.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the last vision of Ezekiel's book. After the return of the glory, a river flows from the threshold of the temple. It grows deeper as it moves toward the Dead Sea, and wherever it goes, it brings life. Then the land is divided fairly among the tribes, including foreigners who live among them. The book ends with the new name of the city, a promise that answers the sorrow of the first part: the glory had left, and now God is present forever.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, water was issuing from below the threshold of the temple toward the east" (47:1).
2. "Again he measured a thousand, and led me through the water, water that was to the ankles... to the knees... to the loins" (47:3-4).
3. "It was a river that I could not pass through, for the water had risen. It was deep enough to swim in" (47:5).
4. "This water flows toward the eastern region and goes down into the Arabah, and enters the Sea. When the water flows into the Sea, the water of the Sea will become fresh" (47:8).
5. "Swarms of creatures will live wherever the river goes... everything will live where the river goes" (47:9).

6. “On the banks, on both sides of the river, there will grow all kinds of trees for food. Their leaves will not wither, nor their fruit fail” (47:12).

7. “You shall divide it for an inheritance among yourselves and for the sojourners who reside among you” (47:22).

8. “And the name of the city from that time on shall be, The LORD Is There” (48:35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The river begins as a trickle under the temple threshold. Following the guide, Ezekiel wades in at the ankles, then the knees, then the waist, and then it is a river he cannot cross. The image is of overflowing, increasing grace. A small source from the presence of God becomes a flood of life. And the direction is downhill into the Judean desert, to the Dead Sea, the most lifeless place on earth. The salty water becomes fresh, and fish swarm there. Fishermen stand on the shore. The river brings life even to death.

On the banks, fruit trees grow every month. The leaves do not wither. The fruit is for food, and the leaves for healing. And the reason is stated: “because the water for them flows from the sanctuary.” All life flows from the presence of God. This is Eden restored.

The rest of the chapter deals with the boundaries of the land and the division among the tribes. Notable is the inclusion of the sojourners: “You shall allot it for an inheritance among yourselves and for the foreigners who reside among you and have fathered children among you. You shall treat them as native-born Israelites.” The covenant community is extended to include outsiders.

Chapter 48 lists the tribal portions, each as a strip running east to west, with the holy portion at the center. The city has twelve gates, named for the twelve tribes. And the book ends with its last line: “The name of the city from that time on shall be, The LORD Is There.” It is a fitting end for a book that began with God’s glory leaving. The glory is back, and it will not leave again.

For the Christian, the river is a picture of the Spirit and the gospel, flowing from the presence of God to the dead places of the world. It finds its fulfillment in Revelation 22.

STEP 5

Connection

John 7:37-39 says that Jesus invited anyone who is thirsty to come, and that out of his heart will flow rivers of living water, referring to the Spirit. Revelation 22:1-2 describes the river of the water of life flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb, with the tree of life on both

banks, “and the leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations.” Revelation 21:3 says, “The dwelling place of God is with man.” Revelation 21:12-14 describes the city with twelve gates. Ephesians 2:19 says that Gentiles are no longer strangers but fellow citizens.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a “Dead Sea” in your life or community. Pray for the river of God’s life to reach it.

Ask whether the grace you have received is deeper than “ankle-deep.” Wade further in.

Welcome a stranger into your community, as the tribes were told to welcome the sojourners.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to let the river of his life flow into dead places in you.
- Thank Jesus, the source of living water.
- Pray for a place that is barren.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 70

“If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up.”

DANIEL 3:17-18

DAY 486 · WEEK 70

Daniel 1:1-2:49

Faithfulness in exile; Nebuchadnezzar's dream

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Daniel 1:1-2:49. A young man taken to Babylon refuses to compromise, and later interprets a king's dream about a statue and a stone. Notice how Daniel and his friends live as exiles, and notice what the dream says about the kingdoms of the earth.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Daniel was taken to Babylon as a teenager in 605 BC, in the first deportation. He and three friends were selected to be trained for the king's service. Daniel is the book that addresses the question of how God's people live in a foreign empire. It is written partly in Hebrew and partly in Aramaic, the language of international affairs (2:4 to 7:28). It moves from stories of faithfulness in the first six chapters to visions of the future in the last six.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But Daniel resolved that he would not defile himself with the king's food" (1:8).
2. "God gave these four youths learning and skill in all literature and wisdom" (1:17).
3. "Let the name of God be blessed forever and ever, to whom belong wisdom and might" (2:20).
4. "He changes times and seasons; he removes kings and sets up kings" (2:21).
5. "No wise men, enchanters, magicians, or astrologers can show to the king the mystery that the king has asked, but there is a God in heaven who reveals mysteries" (2:27-28).
6. "You, O king, were looking, and behold, a great image" (2:31).
7. "A stone was cut out by no human hand, and it struck the image on its feet of iron and clay, and broke them in pieces" (2:34).

8 “And in the days of those kings the God of heaven will set up a kingdom that shall never be destroyed” (2:44).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first chapter shows the pressure of assimilation. The young men are renamed with Babylonian names that honor Babylonian gods, taught a new language and literature, and given food from the king’s table. Daniel draws a line at the food, probably because it had been offered to idols or violated the law. He does so respectfully, asks for a test, and God honors it. Faithfulness here is both principled and wise. They serve the empire well, and God gives them skill. The lesson is that we can serve in a foreign place without compromising our loyalty to God.

Chapter 2 introduces the first great vision. Nebuchadnezzar has a dream that troubles him, and he demands that his wise men tell him both the dream and its meaning. They cannot. The king orders them all killed, including Daniel. Daniel asks for time and prays with his friends. God reveals the dream in the night. Daniel’s response is a hymn of praise: “Blessed be the name of God forever and ever, to whom belong wisdom and might. He changes times and seasons; he removes kings and sets up kings.” Before he tells the king, he gives God the credit. And in front of the king, he says plainly: “No wise men… can show the king the mystery, but there is a God in heaven who reveals mysteries.”

The dream is of a great statue with a head of gold, chest of silver, belly of bronze, legs of iron, and feet of iron mixed with clay. A stone, not cut by human hands, strikes the feet, and the whole statue becomes dust. The stone grows into a mountain that fills the earth. Daniel interprets: the head is Nebuchadnezzar, and the other metals are successive kingdoms. The stone is the kingdom that God will set up, which will never be destroyed. The message is that the great empires of human history will pass, and God’s kingdom will last forever.

Nebuchadnezzar falls on his face and acknowledges Daniel’s God as “God of gods and Lord of kings.” Though the king’s confession is incomplete, it shows that God’s hand can reach even the rulers of the earth.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the stone that the builders rejected (Matthew 21:42-44; 1 Peter 2:4-8). Luke 1:33 says of Jesus, “Of his kingdom there will be no end.” Matthew 6:10 teaches us to pray, “Your kingdom come.” Romans 12:2 says, “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed.” Colossians 2:3 says that in Christ are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge. 1 Peter 2:11-12 calls us to live as exiles with good conduct.

STEP 6

Application

Where do you face pressure to compromise? Decide, as Daniel did, what you will not defile yourself with, and do it graciously.

Pray with friends, as Daniel did, when you face a situation you cannot handle on your own.

Praise God before you ask for his help. Say Daniel 2:20-21 aloud.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bless the name of God, to whom wisdom and might belong.

Ask him to help you stand firm in a foreign place.

Thank him that he changes times and seasons.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 70

"If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up."

DANIEL 3:17-18

DAY 487 · WEEK 70

Daniel 3:1-4:37

The fiery furnace; Nebuchadnezzar humbled

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Daniel 3:1-4:37. Three men are thrown into a furnace for refusing to bow, and a fourth appears with them. Then Nebuchadnezzar, the proudest man on earth, is humbled and learns that Heaven rules. Read the three men's reply in 3:16-18 carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 3 happens some years after the dream of chapter 2. Nebuchadnezzar builds a gold statue ninety feet high and commands everyone to bow when the music plays. Three of Daniel's friends, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, refuse. Chapter 4 is a first-person account from the king himself, a testimony of how God humbled him for his pride, then restored him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king" (3:17).
2. "But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up" (3:18).
3. "Behold, I see four men unbound, walking in the midst of the fire, and they are not hurt; and the appearance of the fourth is like a son of the gods" (3:25).
4. "Blessed be the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, who has sent his angel and delivered his servants" (3:28).
5. "The Most High rules the kingdom of men and gives it to whom he will" (4:17).

6. “Is not this great Babylon, which I have built by my mighty power as a royal residence and for the glory of my majesty?” (4:30).
7. “At the end of the days I, Nebuchadnezzar, lifted my eyes to heaven, and my reason returned to me” (4:34).
8. “And those who walk in pride he is able to humble” (4:37).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three men’s reply to the king is among the greatest declarations of faith in the Bible. They do not argue or beg. They say that God is able to deliver them. And they add: “But if not.” Their obedience does not depend on a miracle. They will not bow whether or not God rescues them. This is faith that is not tied to outcome. It trusts God’s character, not his results.

The furnace is heated seven times hotter. It is so hot that it kills the soldiers who throw them in. But inside, there are four men walking, unbound, and the fourth looks like a son of the gods. The rescue shows that God is present in the fire. He does not always spare us from the furnace, but he is with us in it. When they come out, they do not even smell of smoke. The king blesses their God and decrees that no one may speak against him.

Chapter 4 is the king’s personal story. He has a dream of a great tree that is cut down, and Daniel tells him that the tree is himself. For seven periods of time, he will be driven from among men and live like an animal, until he acknowledges that Heaven rules. Daniel gives pastoral advice: “Break off your sins by practicing righteousness, and your iniquities by showing mercy to the oppressed.” A year later, while walking on his roof, the king boasts of Babylon, “which I have built by my mighty power.” The words are still in his mouth when judgment falls.

When his sanity returns, he lifts his eyes to heaven and blesses the Most High. His testimony ends with a statement of the book’s theme: “All his works are right and his ways are just; and those who walk in pride he is able to humble.” The greatest emperor of the age is brought to confess what Daniel’s friends knew all along.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 43:2 says, “When you pass through the waters, I will be with you… when you walk through fire you shall not be burned.” Hebrews 11:34 mentions those who “quenched the power of fire.” Acts 5:29: “We must obey God rather than men.” Revelation 13:15 shows a

similar demand to worship an image. Matthew 1:23: Immanuel, God with us. Proverbs 16:18 says pride goes before destruction. 1 Peter 5:5-6 says, “God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble.”

STEP 6

Application

Pray “But if not” for a situation where you do not know how God will act. Commit to obedience regardless of the outcome.

Take comfort that Jesus is with you in your furnace.

Examine your own “Is not this great Babylon?” boast. Where might God be humbling pride in you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what fire you are facing.

Say, “Even if he does not,” and tell him whom you will serve.

Thank him that he walks with you in the fire.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 70

“If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up.”

DANIEL 3:17-18

DAY 488 · WEEK 70

Psalm 135

Praise the name of the LORD

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 135. It is a hymn of praise that celebrates the LORD's greatness over the idols of the nations. Notice how it echoes Daniel's chapters: the God of Israel against the gods of Babylon.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 135 is a hymn built from other Scripture. It quotes Exodus, Deuteronomy, Jeremiah, and other psalms. It was sung after the exile as the community recalled what God had done. It comes at the right place in this unit, after the stories of Daniel, where the living God confronts idols and kings. The psalm mocks idols and praises God for his choice of Israel. It will appear again later in the plan.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Praise the name of the LORD, give praise, O servants of the LORD" (v. 1).
2. "For I know that the LORD is great, and that our Lord is above all gods" (v. 5).
3. "Whatever the LORD pleases, he does, in heaven and on earth, in the seas and all deeps" (v. 6).
4. "He it was who struck down the firstborn of Egypt, both of man and of beast" (v. 8).
5. "Your name, O LORD, endures forever, your renown, O LORD, throughout all ages" (v. 13).
6. "The idols of the nations are silver and gold, the work of human hands" (v. 15).
7. "They have mouths, but do not speak; they have eyes, but do not see" (vv. 16-17).

8 “Those who make them become like them, so do all who trust in them” (v. 18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a call to praise and quickly gives reasons: the LORD is good, he chose Jacob, and he is great. The key statement is in verse 6: “Whatever the LORD pleases, he does.” This is God’s sovereignty. Unlike the idols, he acts, in the heavens and on earth. He makes clouds rise, lightning flash, and wind come from his storehouses. In history, he struck down the firstborn of Egypt and defeated kings such as Sihon and Og. He gave their land as a heritage to Israel.

The psalm then contrasts God with idols. The idols are silver and gold, the work of human hands. They have mouths but cannot speak, eyes but cannot see, ears but cannot hear, and there is no breath in their mouths. The list is almost comical, and it is exactly the argument Isaiah and Jeremiah made. And the psalm ends with the most striking line: “Those who make them become like them; so do all who trust in them.” We become like what we worship. People who worship dead things become dead. They lose sight, hearing, and speech. Those who worship the living God become alive.

The final section widens the call to praise. The house of Israel, the house of Aaron, the house of Levi, and all who fear the LORD are summoned to bless him. And the last line is: “Blessed be the LORD from Zion, he who dwells in Jerusalem! Praise the LORD!”

For the exiles, who saw the grandeur of Babylon’s temples and idols, this was an important reminder. The gods of the empire were silent and powerless. The God of Israel, who seemed to be defeated, was alive and in control. The statue of Daniel 2 and the image of Daniel 3 were nothing before him.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 14:15-17 and 17:24-29 use this argument to preach to pagans. 1 Corinthians 8:4-6 says there is no God but one. Romans 1:22-23 says people who exchange the glory of God for images become fools. 2 Corinthians 3:18 says that beholding the glory of the Lord, we are being transformed into the same image. 1 Peter 2:9 calls the church a chosen race, God’s own possession, to proclaim his excellencies. Revelation 4:11 praises the worthy Lord and God.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you tend to worship that cannot speak, see, or hear. What are you becoming like?

Use this psalm as a call to praise. Name what the LORD has done as a list in your own words.

Say verse 6 as a statement of trust: “Whatever the LORD pleases, he does.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as great above all gods.
- Confess any idol of silver and gold, literal or modern.
- Thank him for what he pleases to do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 70

“If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up.”

DANIEL 3:17-18

DAY 489 · WEEK 70

Psalm 136

His steadfast love endures forever

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Psalm · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 136. Every verse ends with the same refrain: “for his steadfast love endures forever.” Read it aloud if you can, as a litany, with the second half as a response.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 136 is called the Great Hallel in Jewish tradition and is sung at Passover. It is a liturgy: one voice would say the first line, and the congregation would respond with the refrain. It recounts creation and the exodus and the conquest in the language of God’s steadfast love. After Daniel’s stories, it is a fitting close to Unit 13’s reading of the exile: the God who is sovereign over empires is the God whose love endures forever. It will return later in the plan.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 1).
2. “Give thanks to the God of gods, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 2).
3. “To him who alone does great wonders, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 4).
4. “To him who by understanding made the heavens, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 5).
5. “To him who struck down the firstborn of Egypt, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 10).
6. “To him who divided the Red Sea in two” (v. 13).
7. “It is he who remembered us in our low estate, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 23).
8. “He who gives food to all flesh, for his steadfast love endures forever” (v. 25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The refrain, repeated twenty-six times, is the heart of the psalm. “His steadfast love endures forever.” The Hebrew word hesed, covenant love, is the theme. The psalm teaches that every act of God, in creation, in redemption, and in daily provision, flows from this love.

The structure is a story. The first section is creation: God made the heavens by understanding, spread out the earth, and made the great lights. The sun rules the day, and the moon and stars the night. The creation is not an accident or a conflict but a gift of love. The second section is redemption: God struck down the firstborn of Egypt, brought out Israel with a strong hand, divided the sea, and led his people through the wilderness. Even the destruction of the enemy kings is told as part of this love. The point is not cruelty but faithfulness to the covenant. The third section is the land given as a heritage.

Then there is a turn in verse 23: “It is he who remembered us in our low estate.” This is likely about the exile and the return. In the lowest point of the people’s history, God did not forget. And so the psalm ends with the universal provision of God: “He who gives food to all flesh,” and a final call: “Give thanks to the God of heaven, for his steadfast love endures forever.”

Reading Psalm 136 after the book of Lamentations is powerful. In Lamentations 3:22, the poet says, “The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases.” Here it is made into a song. After a unit about judgment, exile, and the fall of nations, the closing word is not wrath but love that endures.

STEP 5

Connection

1 John 4:8 says, “God is love.” Romans 8:38-39 says nothing can separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord. Ephesians 2:4-5 says, “God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive.” John 3:16 shows God’s love in giving his Son. Matthew 26:30 says that Jesus and his disciples sang a hymn after the Last Supper, probably the Hallel.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Psalm 136 as a litany, aloud, with a friend or family member. One person reads the first line, and the other answers the refrain.

Add your own verses: “To him who … for his steadfast love endures forever.” Name three things from your own life.

Remember a time God “remembered you in your low estate.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give thanks to God, line by line, for his steadfast love in your own story.

Remember how he remembered you in your low estate.

Give thanks to the God of heaven.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 70

"If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up."

DANIEL 3:17-18

DAY 490 · WEEK 70

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Daniel 3:17-18 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up."

DANIEL 3:17-18

REST

Meditation

These words were spoken by three young men facing death. They stand at the center of the book of Daniel, and they define what faithfulness looks like when the stakes are highest.

"Our God whom we serve is able to deliver us." The first statement is about God's ability. They do not doubt that he can save them. They believe in a God who is powerful enough to rescue from a furnace seven times hotter than normal. They call him "our God whom we serve," because their relationship is one of service. It is a statement of confidence.

"And he will deliver us out of your hand, O king." The second statement is of expectation. They think God will rescue them. They are not stoic, bracing for the worst. They hope in God.

“But if not.” These two words are among the most powerful in Scripture. They show that their faith is not conditional. If God does not rescue them, their obedience stands. They do not make their loyalty depend on getting what they want from God. Their faith is in God himself, not in his rescue.

“Be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods.” The conclusion is a clear statement of allegiance. They do not argue about the details of the law. They simply refuse. And what follows is the rescue, with the fourth figure in the fire.

For the Christian, this is a model of faith in uncertain times. We pray for deliverance, believe that God can, and believe that he will. And we commit to obey in either case. Say this verse when you face a situation where the outcome is unknown. The God who is able is also with you in the fire.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the last chapters of Ezekiel and began the book of Daniel. You prayed Psalms 128, 129, 131, 133, and 134, with their blessing of home and unity, their quiet trust, and their night blessing. In Ezekiel, you heard the watchman renewed, God’s promise to be the shepherd himself, the new heart and the Spirit within, the dry bones that lived, the final defeat of Gog, and the vision of the glory returning to a new temple. You read the river flowing from the sanctuary and bringing life to the Dead Sea, and the book’s last words: “The LORD Is There.” Then you met Daniel: the young man who would not defile himself, the dream of the statue and the stone, the three men in the fiery furnace, and the proud king humbled. Psalms 135 and 136 closed the week with God’s sovereignty over idols and his steadfast love that endures forever. The week taught that God himself will make his people new, that he dwells among them, and that faithfulness in exile is possible.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Ezekiel’s river grows deeper as it flows, giving life to the Dead Sea. What place in your life or community needs God’s river of life?

Daniel and his friends lived faithfully in a foreign empire. What are the “Babylonian” pressures in your life, and what would faithful, gracious resistance look like?

The three men said, “But if not.” How does that kind of faith, not dependent on the outcome, challenge or comfort you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God that he is able to deliver you.

Thank him that he walks with you in the fire.

Rest in him today.

DAY 491 · WEEK 71

Daniel 5:1-6:28

The writing on the wall; the den of lions

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Daniel 5:1-6:28. A king's feast ends with a hand writing on the wall, and an elderly Daniel is thrown into a den of lions for praying. Read the two stories together as the fall of the proud and the rescue of the faithful.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 5 takes place in 539 BC, the night Babylon fell to the Medes and Persians. Belshazzar, the crown prince and co-regent, holds a great feast and uses the sacred vessels from Jerusalem's temple as drinking cups. Chapter 6 takes place under Darius the Mede, in the early years of Persian rule. Daniel is now an old man of about eighty, and his enemies set a trap using his prayer life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Belshazzar... gave command to bring the gold and silver vessels that Nebuchadnezzar his father had taken out of the temple in Jerusalem" (5:2).
2. "Immediately the fingers of a human hand appeared and wrote on the plaster of the wall" (5:5).
3. "You have not humbled your heart, though you knew all this, but you have lifted up yourself against the Lord of heaven" (5:22-23).
4. "MENE, MENE, TEKEL, and PARSIN" (5:25).
5. "You have been weighed in the balances and found wanting" (5:27).
6. "That very night Belshazzar the Chaldean king was killed" (5:30).

7. “When Daniel knew that the document had been signed, he went to his house… and he got down on his knees three times a day and prayed and gave thanks before his God, as he had done previously” (6:10).

8. “My God sent his angel and shut the lions” mouths, and they have not harmed me, because I was found blameless before him’ (6:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Belshazzar’s feast shows the arrogance of a ruler who has learned nothing. His grandfather Nebuchadnezzar had been humbled, yet he drinks from the vessels of God’s temple and praises the gods of gold and silver. The hand appears, and the king is terrified, his knees knocking. The wise men cannot read it. The queen mother recommends Daniel. He refuses the reward and reads the sentence: God has numbered the days of your kingdom, weighed you, and divided it. The words are about weights: a mina, a shekel, and half-shekels. The reading is clear: the kingdom is over. That very night, Babylon fell.

The charge is that Belshazzar knew what had happened to Nebuchadnezzar and did not humble himself. Knowledge without humility is the greater guilt. “The God in whose hand is your breath, and whose are all your ways, you have not honored.”

Chapter 6 is a contrast. Daniel’s enemies, jealous of his rank, can find no fault in him except “in the law of his God.” They persuade the king to sign a decree that no one may pray to any god or man except the king for thirty days. Daniel, hearing it, does exactly what he had always done. He goes to his upper room, opens his windows toward Jerusalem, and prays three times a day. He does not make a show, and does not hide. He simply continues.

He is thrown to the lions. The king, who loves him, spends a sleepless night. At dawn, Daniel is alive. “My God sent his angel and shut the lions” mouths.’ The king issues a new decree: that in all his kingdom people are to tremble before the God of Daniel, “for he is the living God, enduring forever; his kingdom shall never be destroyed.”

Two kings, two responses. Belshazzar lifted himself up and fell. Daniel humbled himself in prayer and was preserved. The difference is not strength but allegiance.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Pray then like this: Our Father in heaven” (Matthew 6:9), and told his disciples to pray always (Luke 18:1). 1 Thessalonians 5:17 says to pray without ceasing. Hebrews 11:33 mentions those who “stopped the mouths of lions.” Acts 5:29 says we must obey God rather

than men. 2 Timothy 4:17 says Paul was rescued from the lion's mouth. Psalm 1:2 says the blessed person meditates on the law day and night. Revelation 14:8 echoes "Fallen, fallen is Babylon."

STEP 6

Application

Establish a regular, consistent prayer rhythm, even if no one sees. Let it be as natural as breathing.

Examine whether you have "weighed" yourself against God's standard. Thank God that Christ was weighed in your place.

Pray for those facing opposition because of their faith.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from lifting yourself against him.
- Ask him to teach you to pray as Daniel did, with steady faithfulness.
- Thank him that your breath and ways are in his hand.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 71

"And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel."

EZRA 3:11

DAY 492 · WEEK 71

Daniel 7:1-8:27

The Son of Man; the four beasts

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Daniel 7:1-8:27. The second half of Daniel begins with visions. Four beasts rise from the sea, and one like a son of man comes with the clouds of heaven. Read chapter 7 slowly, especially verses 9 to 14. This is one of the most important passages in the Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The visions of Daniel 7 and 8 date to about 553 and 551 BC, before the events of chapters 5 and 6, but they are placed here to open the apocalyptic part of the book. The visions use symbolic beasts to describe the empires of the earth. In chapter 7, which is in Aramaic, Daniel sees four beasts and then a heavenly courtroom. In chapter 8, he sees a ram and a goat, which many interpreters understand as Persia and Greece.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Four great beasts came up out of the sea, different from one another” (7:3).
2. “As I looked, thrones were placed, and the Ancient of Days took his seat” (7:9).
3. “His clothing was white as snow, and the hair of his head like pure wool; his throne was fiery flames” (7:9).
4. “A stream of fire issued and came out from before him” (7:10).
5. “Behold, with the clouds of heaven there came one like a son of man, and he came to the Ancient of Days and was presented before him” (7:13).
6. “And to him was given dominion and glory and a kingdom, that all peoples, nations, and languages should serve him” (7:14).

7. “His dominion is an everlasting dominion, which shall not pass away, and his kingdom one that shall not be destroyed” (7:14).

8. “And the kingdom and the dominion and the greatness of the kingdoms under the whole heaven shall be given to the people of the saints of the Most High” (7:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The four beasts are a lion with eagle’s wings, a bear raised on one side, a leopard with four heads, and a terrifying fourth beast with iron teeth and ten horns. They are usually understood as successive empires: Babylon, Persia, Greece, and Rome or a later power. They rise from the chaotic sea. The fourth has a little horn that speaks great things and wages war against the saints. The beasts show the nature of human empires: violent, devouring, and arrogant.

Then the scene shifts. Thrones are set, and the Ancient of Days takes his seat. The picture is of a heavenly court. His clothing is white as snow, and his throne is flames of fire with wheels of burning fire. Thousands upon thousands serve him. The books are opened. The beast is slain, and its body burned. The other beasts lose their dominion.

Then comes the climax: “With the clouds of heaven there came one like a son of man.” Clouds are the vehicle of God in the Old Testament. This figure approaches the Ancient of Days and receives everlasting dominion over all peoples. The kingdoms of the beasts rise from the sea. The kingdom of the son of man comes from heaven. Beasts devour, but the son of man is given all authority.

Daniel is troubled by the vision. An attendant explains: the four beasts are four kings. “But the saints of the Most High shall receive the kingdom and possess the kingdom forever.” The Son of Man shares his rule with his people.

Chapter 8 is a second vision of a ram, a goat, and a little horn that desecrates the sanctuary. It looks beyond to the persecution under Antiochus Epiphanes in the second century BC, a type of later enemies. Daniel is overcome by the vision and falls sick. The consistent message: the powers of this world, however terrifying, are limited by God’s decree.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus called himself “the Son of Man” more than eighty times. At his trial, he said to the high priest, “You will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power and coming on the clouds of heaven” (Mark 14:62), and the high priest tore his robes, understanding the claim.

Matthew 28:18: “All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me.” Revelation 1:7, 13-14 shows him coming with the clouds, white-haired. Revelation 13 shows the beast, and Revelation 5 shows the Lamb receiving the kingdom.

STEP 6

Application

Spend time meditating on Daniel 7:13-14, and think about Jesus as the one to whom all dominion is given.

When world powers seem terrifying, remember that the Ancient of Days is on the throne and the books are open.

Pray for those who are persecuted, remembering that the kingdom will be given to the saints.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise the Ancient of Days.
- Thank him for the Son of Man whose kingdom will not pass away.
- Ask him to give you courage in the meantime.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 71

“And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel.”

EZRA 3:11

DAY 493 · WEEK 71

Daniel 9:1-10:21

Daniel's prayer; the 70 weeks

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Daniel 9:1-10:21. Daniel reads Jeremiah, prays one of the greatest prayers of confession in the Bible, and receives the prophecy of the seventy weeks. Then a vision of a glorious man and a message from an angel who was delayed by spiritual conflict. Read the prayer first, and take your time.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 9 is dated to 539 BC, the first year of Darius. Daniel, now an old man, reads Jeremiah's prophecy of seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11-12; 29:10), and realizes that the time is near. He responds by prayer. Chapter 10 is dated three years later, in 536 BC. Daniel is mourning and fasting when he sees a vision of a man in linen, and receives a message about the conflict between spiritual powers.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I, Daniel, perceived in the books the number of years that, according to the word of the LORD to Jeremiah the prophet, must pass before the end of the desolations of Jerusalem" (9:2).
2. "Then I turned my face to the Lord God, seeking him by prayer and pleas for mercy with fasting and sackcloth and ashes" (9:3).
3. "We have sinned and done wrong and acted wickedly and rebelled, turning aside from your commandments" (9:5).
4. "To the Lord our God belong mercy and forgiveness, for we have rebelled against him" (9:9).

5. “For we do not present our pleas before you because of our righteousness, but because of your great mercy” (9:18).
6. “O Lord, hear; O Lord, forgive. O Lord, pay attention and act. For your own sake, O my God, do not delay” (9:19).
7. “Seventy weeks are decreed about your people and your holy city, to finish the transgression, to put an end to sin, and to atone for iniquity, to bring in everlasting righteousness” (9:24).
8. “Fear not, Daniel, for from the first day that you set your heart to understand and humbled yourself before your God, your words have been heard” (10:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Daniel’s prayer is a model. He begins with God’s word: he has read the book and trusts the promise. But the promise leads him to pray, not to relax. He knows that God’s promises are fulfilled in the context of repentance. He fasts and confesses, using the first person plural, “we have sinned,” though Daniel himself is portrayed as blameless. He identifies with the people. He praises God as great and awesome, keeping covenant and steadfast love. He admits that the curses of Moses have fallen because of their disobedience.

Notice what he does not argue. He does not appeal to his own righteousness or to Israel’s merits. “We do not present our pleas before you because of our righteousness, but because of your great mercy.” The appeal is for God’s name’s sake. The prayer is urgent: “O Lord, hear; O Lord, forgive; O Lord, pay attention and act.”

The answer comes by Gabriel, who says that as soon as Daniel began to pray, a word went out. Then the prophecy of the seventy weeks: seventy sevens decreed for the people and the city. Six things are to be accomplished: to finish the transgression, to put an end to sin, to atone for iniquity, to bring in everlasting righteousness, to seal the vision and prophecy, and to anoint a most holy place. These are the great goals of redemption. The details of the timeline are debated, but Christians have long seen in it a pointer to the Messiah, the anointed one, who will be cut off and bring the atonement.

Chapter 10 shows a heavenly dimension. Daniel’s prayer had been heard from the first day, but the angel was delayed 21 days by “the prince of the kingdom of Persia” until Michael came to help. This is a glimpse of spiritual warfare behind the scenes of history. Daniel is strengthened by the angel’s touch: “Peace be with you; be strong and of good courage.”

STEP 5

Connection

1 John 1:9 says, “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins.” Romans 5:6-11 speaks of Christ dying for the ungodly. Hebrews 9:26 says Christ has appeared “to put away sin by the sacrifice of himself,” fulfilling the goals of Daniel 9:24. Ephesians 6:12 says we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against the spiritual forces of evil. Revelation 1:12-18 shows the glorified Christ in a similar picture to Daniel 10.

STEP 6

Application

Use Daniel’s prayer as a pattern. Start with God’s word, confess honestly, appeal to his mercy and not your merit.

Pray for your community or nation, using “we” and not “they.”

Take courage from Daniel 10:12. Your prayers are heard from the first day, even if the answer is delayed.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess your sin and the sin of your people in your own words.
- Tell God you do not plead your righteousness but his mercy.
- Ask him to hear and act for his own name’s sake.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 71

“And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel.”

EZRA 3:11

DAY 494 · WEEK 71

Daniel 11:1-12:13

The kings of north and south; the resurrection of the dead

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Daniel 11:1-12:13. This is a long and detailed prophecy of the conflicts between kings of the north and south. Do not get lost in the details. Read for the ending in chapter 12: the resurrection of the dead, and the final word to Daniel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This last vision comes in 536 BC, and it traces the history of the Persian and Greek empires, and especially the conflicts between the Ptolemies of Egypt (the king of the south) and the Seleucids of Syria (the king of the north). It culminates in the persecution of the Jewish people under Antiochus Epiphanes in the second century BC, and looks beyond to the end times. Chapter 12 gives the clearest statement of resurrection in the Old Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “But the people who know their God shall stand firm and take action” (11:32).
2. “And those who are wise among the people shall make many understand, though for some days they shall stumble by sword and flame” (11:33).
3. “At that time shall arise Michael, the great prince who has charge of your people” (12:1).
4. “And there shall be a time of trouble, such as never has been since there was a nation till that time. But at that time your people shall be delivered, everyone whose name shall be found written in the book” (12:1).
5. “And many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt” (12:2).

6. “And those who are wise shall shine like the brightness of the sky above; and those who turn many to righteousness, like the stars forever and ever” (12:3).
7. “But you, go your way till the end. And you shall rest and shall stand in your allotted place at the end of the days” (12:13).
8. “Shut up the words and seal the book, until the time of the end” (12:4).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 11 is a long survey of history in prophecy, with such detail that critics have claimed it must have been written after the events. Believers see in it the sovereign foreknowledge of God. The point is that history is not random. The kings of the north and south rise and fall, make treaties and break them, and God is working through it. The history culminates in the desecration of the temple by a contemptuous king, and then the picture moves beyond him.

In the midst of the persecution, there is a counterpoint. “The people who know their God shall stand firm and take action.” This is the verse of the chapter. Persecution does not destroy those who know their God. They shall stand firm. And those who are wise will make many understand, even though they stumble by sword and flame. The suffering of the saints is not meaningless: it refines and purifies.

Chapter 12 turns to the end. A time of trouble will come, unlike any before. But Daniel’s people will be delivered, “everyone whose name shall be found written in the book.” Then comes the resurrection promise: “Many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt.” This is one of the clearest teachings of the resurrection of the dead in the Old Testament. Both the righteous and the wicked will rise. The wise will shine like the stars.

The book ends with a personal word to Daniel. He is told to seal the book until the time of the end, and then, tenderly: “But you, go your way till the end. And you shall rest and shall stand in your allotted place at the end of the days.” The old prophet will rest and rise. It is a fitting close to the long unit of exile. After everything, the final word is of rest and resurrection.

STEP 5

Connection

John 5:28-29 says that all who are in the tombs will hear his voice and come out, “those who have done good to the resurrection of life, and those who have done evil to the resurrection of judgment.” 1 Corinthians 15:51-58 speaks of the resurrection. Matthew 24:21 echoes the “time of trouble such as never has been.” Philippians 2:15 says believers shine like stars in the world. Revelation 20:12-15 mentions the book of life. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 comforts us with the hope of resurrection.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Daniel 11:32b: “The people who know their God shall stand firm and take action.” Ask how your knowledge of God can lead to firm action.

Take comfort in the promise of resurrection when you grieve.

Seek to be one who “turns many to righteousness.” Ask whom God may be calling you to encourage in the faith.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you know him and stand firm.
- Thank him that your name is written in his book.
- Thank him for the hope of the resurrection.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 71

“And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel.”

EZRA 3:11

DAY 495 · WEEK 71

Review and Reflection

Unit 13 review, Exile, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel

Year 1 · Unit 13 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people."
>
> JEREMIAH 31:33

REST

Meditation

This is the unit's anchor verse, the heart of the new covenant promise. After the long account of judgment, exile, and loss, it is the answer God gives to the problem of the human heart.

"I will put my law within them." The old covenant was written on stone tablets. It was holy, righteous, and good, but it was external. The people heard it, agreed to it, and broke it. God did not change the law. He changes where it is kept. "Within them." The law moves from tablet to the center of the person.

"And I will write it on their hearts." To write on the heart is to make obedience a matter of desire, not just duty. It is what Ezekiel describes as a new heart and the Spirit within. Where there was resistance, there is delight. Psalm 40:8 says, "I delight to do your will, O my God; your law is within my heart." The new covenant makes this the normal experience of God's people.

"And I will be their God, and they shall be my people." This is the covenant formula running through the whole Bible. It is the goal of redemption: a people who belong to God, and a God who belongs to his people. It is the language of marriage and family. It is also the language of Revelation 21:3.

Say this verse from memory, and think about the unit as a whole. It began with the fall of Jerusalem and ended with promises of a new heart, a new temple, and a kingdom that will never be destroyed. All of this is fulfilled in Jesus, who said at the Last Supper, "This cup is the new covenant in my blood." If you have trusted in him, this promise is for you.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

This unit covered the exile, the darkest period of the Old Testament and one of the richest in hope. Josiah's reform could not undo Manasseh's sin, and Jerusalem fell in 586 BC. Jeremiah, the weeping prophet, warned for forty years, confronted false hope in the temple and in false prophets, and wrote to the exiles that they should seek the welfare of Babylon. At the center of his book is the Book of Consolation, with the promise of a new covenant, in which God writes his law on the heart and forgives sin forever. Lamentations gave voice to grief and found hope in the steadfast love that is new every morning. Ezekiel saw God's glory on a mobile throne in Babylon, watched it leave the temple, and then heard the promise of a heart of flesh, the Spirit within, the dry bones that live, and the return of the glory to a city whose name is "The LORD Is There." Daniel showed what faithful life looks like in a foreign empire: refusing to defile himself, trusting God in the furnace and the lions' den, and seeing the Son of Man receive an everlasting kingdom. The psalms of the unit gave words for lament, trust, and praise.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What is the New Covenant promise in Jeremiah 31?

Recall the four promises: the law written on the heart, a restored relationship, direct knowledge of God, and complete forgiveness. How is this different from the covenant at Sinai? Look at Hebrews 8:6-13 and Luke 22:20 to see how it is fulfilled in Christ.

What does the glory departing from the Temple in Ezekiel 8-11 mean?

Think about the reasons the glory left (the idolatry in the temple), the slow stages of its departure, and what it meant for the exiles. What is the significance of the glory's return in Ezekiel 43, and how does John 1:14 relate?

What does Ezekiel 36-37 promise about the Spirit's work in the New Covenant?

Consider the cleansing water, the new heart and new spirit, and the Spirit within us who causes us to walk in God's statutes. Consider the valley of dry bones. How does Jesus' conversation with Nicodemus in John 3:1-8 draw on this passage?

Who is the Son of Man in Daniel 7, and why is this title important?

Describe the scene: the beasts, the Ancient of Days, and the one like a son of man coming with the clouds. Why did Jesus use this title for himself, and why did the high priest react as he did in Mark 14:61-64?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for writing his law on your heart.

Thank him for what you have learned through the exile.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 14 · DAYS 496-564

The Return and the Chronicles Perspective

Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther, Chronicles, Joel, Obadiah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi

A partial return. God keeps his promises but the full restoration awaits.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"Behold, your king is coming to you; righteous and having salvation is he, humble and mounted on a donkey."

ZECHARIAH 9:9

Songs of return (85, 107, 126), the closing praise psalms (145 to 150), the reign psalms (96 to 99), and temple psalms (115, 132, 135, 136).

UNIT 14

In this unit

WEEK 71

496	Ezra 1:1-3:13	*Reading*
497	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 72

498	Ezra 4:1-6:22	*Reading*
499	Psalm 126	*Psalm*
500	Psalm 85	*Psalm*
501	Psalm 107:1-22	*Psalm*
502	Ezra 7:1-8:36	*Reading*
503	Ezra 9:1-10:44	*Reading*
504	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 73

505	Nehemiah 1:1-2:20	*Reading*
506	Nehemiah 3:1-4:23	*Reading*
507	Nehemiah 5:1-7:73	*Reading*
508	Psalm 147	*Psalm*
509	Psalm 148	*Psalm*
510	Nehemiah 8:1-10:39	*Reading*
511	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 74

512	Nehemiah 11:1-13:31	*Reading*
513	Esther 1:1-3:15	*Reading*
514	Esther 4:1-7:10	*Reading*
515	Esther 8:1-10:3	*Reading*
516	Psalm 145	*Psalm*
517	Psalm 149; Psalm 150	*Psalm*

518	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 75

519	Psalm 115	*Psalm*
520	Psalm 71	*Psalm*
521	Psalm 144	*Psalm*
522	1 Chronicles 1:1-2:55	*Reading*
523	1 Chronicles 3:1-5:26	*Reading*
524	1 Chronicles 6:1-9:44	*Reading*
525	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 76

526	1 Chronicles 10:1-13:14	*Reading*
527	1 Chronicles 14:1-17:27	*Reading*
528	Psalm 96	*Psalm*
529	Psalm 105:1-15	*Psalm*
530	1 Chronicles 18:1-22:19	*Reading*
531	1 Chronicles 23:1-26:32	*Reading*
532	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 77

533	1 Chronicles 27:1-29:30	*Reading*
534	2 Chronicles 1:1-4:22	*Reading*
535	2 Chronicles 5:1-7:22	*Reading*
536	Psalm 132	*Psalm*
537	Psalm 135	*Psalm*
538	Psalm 136	*Psalm*
539	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 78

540	2 Chronicles 8:1-12:16	*Reading*
541	2 Chronicles 13:1-16:14	*Reading*
542	2 Chronicles 17:1-20:37	*Reading*

543	2 Chronicles 21:1-24:27	*Reading*
544	2 Chronicles 25:1-28:27	*Reading*
545	2 Chronicles 29:1-32:33	*Reading*
546	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 79

547	2 Chronicles 33:1-36:23	*Reading*
548	Joel 1:1-2:32	*Reading*
549	Joel 3:1-21	*Reading*
550	Obadiah 1:1-21	*Reading*
551	Psalm 97	*Psalm*
552	Psalm 98	*Psalm*
553	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 80

554	Psalm 99	*Psalm*
555	Haggai 1:1-2:23	*Reading*
556	Zechariah 1:1-3:10	*Reading*
557	Zechariah 4:1-6:15	*Reading*
558	Zechariah 7:1-8:23	*Reading*
559	Zechariah 9:1-11:17	*Reading*
560	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 81

561	Zechariah 12:1-14:21	*Reading*
562	Malachi 1:1-2:17	*Reading*
563	Malachi 3:1-4:6	*Reading*
564	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 496 · WEEK 71

Ezra 1:1-3:13

The return decreed; the Temple foundation, joy and weeping

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 69 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezra 1:1-3:13. A pagan king releases the exiles, and a remnant returns to rebuild the temple. The chapter ends with a sound that is half laughter and half weeping. Read the last verses slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the final unit of the Old Testament. It covers about 150 years, from the decree of Cyrus in 538 BC to the close of the prophets around 400 BC. The exile ended just as Jeremiah said, after seventy years. Ezra and Nehemiah tell what happened next. Chronicles retells the whole story for the returned community. The theme of the unit is a partial return: God keeps his promises, but the full restoration is still to come.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “In the first year of Cyrus king of Persia, that the word of the LORD by the mouth of Jeremiah might be fulfilled, the LORD stirred up the spirit of Cyrus” (1:1).
2. “Whoever is among you of all his people, may his God be with him, and let him go up to Jerusalem” (1:3).
3. Cyrus returned the temple vessels that Nebuchadnezzar had taken (1:7-11).
4. About 42,360 people returned, along with servants and singers (2:64-65).
5. “Then Jeshua… and his kinsmen… arose and built the altar of the God of Israel” (3:2).
6. “They set up the altar on its foundation, for fear was on them because of the peoples of the lands” (3:3).

7. “And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel” (3:11).

8. “Many of the priests and Levites and heads of fathers” houses, old men who had seen the first house, wept with a loud voice when they saw the foundation of this house’ (3:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Ezra begins by repeating the last verses of 2 Chronicles. God “stirred up the spirit of Cyrus,” the same Cyrus Isaiah had named by name 150 years earlier. The mightiest king in the world was moved by the LORD to send his people home. God works through pagan kings as easily as through prophets.

Only a remnant goes. Of the hundreds of thousands in exile, about 42,000 make the journey. Most stayed in Babylon, comfortable and settled. The ones who go are those whose spirits God stirred. Return costs something. The list in chapter 2 is full of names, as if to say that God knows each family who made that trip.

Their first act is not building a house for themselves. They build the altar. “For fear was on them because of the peoples of the lands,” yet they begin with worship. Then, in the second year, they lay the temple foundation. The priests blow trumpets, the Levites clash cymbals, and the people sing the refrain you met in Psalm 136: “He is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel.”

Then comes the strange mixture. Many shout for joy. But the old men who remembered Solomon’s temple weep aloud, because this foundation is so small by comparison. “The sound was heard far away.” No one could tell the shouts of joy from the sound of weeping. That is the mark of the whole unit. The return is real, and it is smaller than the promise. The people have come home, but they are still under Persia, and the glory has not yet returned. Joy and sorrow sit side by side, and both are right.

STEP 5

Connection

Haggai 2:3 asks, “Who is left among you who saw this house in its former glory?” Jesus began with small things: a mustard seed (Matthew 13:31-32). Zechariah 4:10 says, “Who has despised the day of small things?” Romans 8:23 says that we groan inwardly as we wait for redemption, though we have the first fruits of the Spirit. Philippians 1:6 promises that God who began a good work will bring it to completion.

STEP 6

Application

Where has God given you a beginning that seems small compared to what you hoped? Thank him for it anyway.

Build your altar first: begin your day or your project with worship.

Be honest that joy and sorrow can coexist. You do not have to choose only one.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to stir your spirit to go where he calls.
- Thank him for bringing a remnant home.
- Tell him what you want to rebuild.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 71

"And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel."

EZRA 3:11

DAY 497 · WEEK 71

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Ezra 3:11 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel."

EZRA 3:11

REST

Meditation

This sentence was sung by a small group of people standing in front of a foundation. They had come back to a ruined city. The walls were down. The temple was a pile of stones. And they sang.

"They sang responsively." One group sang a line, and another answered. Worship together has a shape: we speak to each other and to God. No one is alone. In a time of rebuilding, they needed each other's voices.

"Praising and giving thanks to the LORD." The foundation was only a foundation. But they praised God for what he had done, not for what was finished. Gratitude does not wait until the work is complete.

“For he is good.” This is the reason for praise: God himself, not their circumstances. The circumstances were mixed. The old men were weeping. Persia was still in charge. Enemies were waiting. But God was good.

“For his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel.” The word “endures” reminds us that the exile did not end it. Seventy years of captivity could not cancel God’s covenant love. It is the same refrain as Psalm 136 and the same truth as Lamentations 3. Their song was an act of faith: the God who sent them away has brought them back.

Say this verse whenever you stand at the foundation of something that is not yet finished. You do not have to wait for the walls to go up. Sing now.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the Old Testament’s exile story and began its last chapter. You finished Daniel with the writing on the wall, the lions’ den, the vision of the Son of Man, and the promise of resurrection. Then, on the first day of Unit 14, you read the decree of Cyrus and followed the first returning exiles home. You saw them build the altar before the temple, and lay the foundation to the sound of trumpets, cymbals, and a song of thanks. And you heard the sound that mixes shouting with weeping. The week taught that God keeps his promises and moves the hearts of kings, that he brings his people home, and that the return, though real, is still only a beginning.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The returning exiles built the altar before they built anything else. What would it look like to put worship first in your day, your work, or your home?

The old men wept when they saw the small foundation. Is there something in your life that is smaller than you hoped, and how might God want you to receive it?

God stirred up the spirit of Cyrus, a pagan king, to fulfill his word. Where have you seen God work through someone who did not know him?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give thanks to God for his steadfast love.

Thank him for bringing his people home.

Rest in him.

DAY 498 · WEEK 72

Ezra 4:1-6:22

Opposition; the Temple completed; Passover kept

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezra 4:1-6:22. Enemies stop the work for about fifteen years, and God uses two prophets to restart it. The temple is finished, and the people keep the Passover. Read for the way opposition is met.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The neighbors of the returning Jews, resettled peoples of the former northern kingdom, offered to help build the temple. When Zerubbabel and Jeshua refused, they became enemies. They discouraged the builders, bribed officials, and finally wrote letters to the Persian court. The work stopped from about 536 to 520 BC. Haggai and Zechariah, whom you will read near the end of this unit, then preached, and the work resumed. The temple was finished in 516 BC, seventy years after its destruction.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “You have nothing to do with us in building a house to our God” (4:3).
2. “Then the people of the land discouraged the people of Judah and made them afraid to build” (4:4).
3. “Then the work on the house of God in Jerusalem stopped” (4:24).
4. “Then the prophets, Haggai and Zechariah the son of Iddo, prophesied to the Jews” (5:1).
5. “But the eye of their God was on the elders of the Jews, and they were not stopped” (5:5).
6. “We are the servants of the God of heaven and earth, and we are rebuilding the house that was built many years ago” (5:11).

7. “And the elders of the Jews built and prospered through the prophesying of Haggai the prophet” (6:14).

8. “And they kept the Feast of Unleavened Bread seven days with joy, for the LORD had made them joyful” (6:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The conflict begins with an offer that sounds friendly. The local peoples say, “Let us build with you, for we worship your God.” Zerubbabel refuses. It was not unkind but wise. These people had mixed the worship of the LORD with other gods (2 Kings 17:33). To build together would have meant a compromised temple. The refusal cost them, because opposition followed: discouragement, fear, bribes, and accusations. Tactics of those who oppose God’s work have not changed.

The work stops. For sixteen years, the foundation sits unfinished. The people turn to their own homes. This is a lesson in how a good beginning can stall when we are tired, afraid, or distracted.

But God sends help. Haggai and Zechariah prophesy, and the leaders rise and start building again. When the governor Tattenai asks who authorized them, the Jews answer with confidence and with their history: “We are the servants of the God of heaven and earth.” A letter is sent to Darius, and he discovers the original decree of Cyrus in the archives. He not only allows the work but orders the provinces to pay for it. The enemies who tried to stop it are made to fund it.

The note in 5:5 is the heart of it: “The eye of their God was on the elders of the Jews, and they were not stopped.” God is watching. The temple is finished in the sixth year of Darius, and the dedication is full of joy. They keep the Passover, as in Hezekiah’s and Josiah’s days. And the writer adds: “The LORD had made them joyful, and had turned the heart of the king of Assyria toward them.” Even the opposition was in God’s hand.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it” (Matthew 16:18). Nehemiah and Paul faced similar opposition (Acts 19, 2 Corinthians 11). 1 Peter 2:5 says we are being built up as a spiritual house. Galatians 6:9 says, “Let us not grow weary of doing good.” Philippians 4:6: do not be anxious. Romans 8:31: if God is for us, who can be against us?

STEP 6

Application

Think about a project God gave you that has stalled. Ask what is needed to start again.

Pray for those who face opposition in their ministry or work.

Be discerning about offers of "help" that would compromise your devotion to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you building when you are afraid or tired.
- Thank him that his eye is on those who serve him.
- Ask him to raise up encouragers around you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 72

"For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel."

EZRA 7:10

DAY 499 · WEEK 72

Psalm 126

When the LORD restored the fortunes of Zion

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 126. You read this psalm in Unit 13 as a hope for the exiles. Now that the first exiles are home, read it again as their own song, sung with the foundation of the temple in front of them.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 126 is a Song of Ascents. Earlier, you read it as a dream of return. Today read it as a song of those who have returned. The joy of verses 1 to 3 is the joy of the day the decree was announced. The prayer of verses 4 to 6 fits the days of delay, opposition, and small beginnings that you have just read in Ezra. It holds both: thanks for what God has done, and a plea for more.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “When the LORD restored the fortunes of Zion, we were like those who dream” (v. 1).
2. “Then our mouth was filled with laughter, and our tongue with shouts of joy” (v. 2).
3. “Then they said among the nations, The LORD has done great things for them” (v. 2).
4. “The LORD has done great things for us; we are glad” (v. 3).
5. “Restore our fortunes, O LORD, like streams in the Negeb!” (v. 4).
6. “Those who sow in tears shall reap with shouts of joy!” (v. 5).
7. “He who goes out weeping, bearing the seed for sowing” (v. 6).
8. “Shall come home with shouts of joy, bringing his sheaves with him” (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a song of already and not yet. In the first half, the people remember the day God restored them. It was so wonderful that it felt like a dream. Laughter, shouts of joy, and even the nations noticing. Ezra 1 and 3 are a commentary on this: a pagan king's decree, the singing at the foundation. They were glad.

But in the second half, there is a request. "Restore our fortunes, O LORD." The returned exiles are back, and yet they still pray for restoration. The land was poor, the walls were broken, the Persians ruled, and the opposition was strong. The first restoration was real, and the work was incomplete. They prayed for more, like the desert streams of the Negeb that burst into life after rain.

Then comes the image of sowing. The farmer goes out weeping because seed is precious, and in a time of famine, it hurts to put it in the ground. He sows in tears, trusting that it will grow. And God promises that he will come back with shouts of joy and with sheaves. The pattern is that tears and joy are connected. Tears are not wasted. They are part of the sowing.

This is what the returned community needed to hear while building the temple under threat. And it is what believers need while waiting for a final restoration. We have tasted the first fruits, and we wait for the harvest. We sow in tears because we live in a world that is not yet made new, and we do it in hope.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, "Blessed are you who weep now, for you shall laugh" (Luke 6:21). John 16:20: "You will be sorrowful, but your sorrow will turn into joy." Galatians 6:9: "In due season we will reap, if we do not give up." 1 Corinthians 15:58: "Your labor is not in vain in the Lord." Romans 8:23-25 describes waiting for the redemption of our bodies. Revelation 21:4 promises no more tears.

STEP 6

Application

Name something you are currently "sowing in tears." Offer it to God, and trust the harvest.

Thank God for a restoration he has already given you, and ask for more.

Encourage someone who is weeping as they work or serve.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the great things he has done for you.

Ask him to restore what is dry in you.

Tell him about tears you are sowing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 72

"For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel."

EZRA 7:10

DAY 500 · WEEK 72

Psalm 85

LORD, you were favorable, will you not revive us again?

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 85. You read this psalm in Unit 13 as a prayer for revival in exile. Read it now as the prayer of people who are back in the land and find that the glory is not what they hoped. Notice again verses 10 to 13.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 85 begins by recalling that God has been favorable to his land and restored the fortunes of Jacob. For the returned exiles, this meant the decree of Cyrus. But the psalm goes on to ask, "Will you not revive us again?" It fits the period of Ezra and Haggai, when the people had returned and still lacked the full blessing. On Day 430 you read it as a lament from the dark side of exile. Today read it as a post-return prayer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "LORD, you were favorable to your land; you restored the fortunes of Jacob" (v. 1).
2. "You forgave the iniquity of your people; you covered all their sin" (v. 2).
3. "Restore us again, O God of our salvation, and put away your indignation toward us!" (v. 4).
4. "Will you be angry with us forever? Will you prolong your anger to all generations?" (v. 5).
5. "Will you not revive us again, that your people may rejoice in you?" (v. 6).
6. "Let me hear what God the LORD will speak, for he will speak peace to his people" (v. 8).
7. "Steadfast love and faithfulness meet; righteousness and peace kiss each other" (v. 10).
8. "Righteousness will go before him and make his footsteps a way" (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The post-return period was a time of mixed feelings. The people had been brought home, but life was hard. Crops failed, the economy was poor, the temple lagged, and neighbors were hostile. Haggai said that they earned wages and put them in a bag with holes. It would have been easy to think that God was still angry.

The psalm answers by returning to history: God has already forgiven. “You covered all their sin.” It is a statement of faith that does not depend on present feelings. The past forgiveness is the ground for the present request. “Restore us again.” We are allowed to ask God to do again what he has already done.

The psalmist then does something wise. He stops talking and listens: “Let me hear what God the LORD will speak.” The word is peace, but with a condition: “Let them not turn back to folly.” Peace is for those who fear him, and God’s salvation is near to them. The glory will dwell in the land.

The great picture follows. Steadfast love and faithfulness meet. Righteousness and peace kiss. Faithfulness springs from the ground and righteousness looks down from heaven. The Lord will give what is good. This is a vision of heaven and earth cooperating. For Ezra’s generation, it was a hope: someday the land would be so blessed. For us it points to Christ, in whom heaven and earth meet.

The last line is a promise of a path: righteousness will go before him and make his footsteps a way. God is coming. His footsteps prepare the road.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 1:78-79 says, “The sunrise shall visit us from on high to give light to those who sit in darkness… to guide our feet into the way of peace.” John 1:14 says the Word became flesh, full of grace and truth. Colossians 1:20 says God made peace by the blood of his cross. Romans 5:1: “Since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God.” Ephesians 2:14: “He himself is our peace.” Isaiah 40:3 speaks of preparing the way of the LORD.

STEP 6

Application

Pray “Will you not revive us again?” for your church or community.

Be still and ask what God is speaking. Listen for five minutes.

Thank God that in Christ, steadfast love and faithfulness have met, and righteousness and peace have kissed.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to revive you.

Ask him to speak peace to you and keep you from turning back to folly.

Thank him that righteousness and peace will kiss.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 72

"For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel."

EZRA 7:10

DAY 501 · WEEK 72

Psalm 107:1-22

Give thanks to the LORD; he gathered the exiles

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 107:1-22. You read this passage on Day 442 as a song of rescue for those in every kind of trouble. Read it now as the psalm of the ones who have actually come home. Let the opening lines be the first words they said.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 107 opens the last book of the Psalter with the words, “Let the redeemed of the LORD say so, whom he has redeemed from trouble and gathered in from the lands.” That is the exact situation of Ezra’s generation. They were gathered from the east, the north, the south, and the west. On Day 442 you read this as the cry of those still waiting. Today, read it as the thanks of those who have returned and are rebuilding.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever!” (v. 1).
2. “Let the redeemed of the LORD say so” (v. 2).
3. “Gathered in from the lands, from the east and from the west, from the north and from the south” (v. 3).
4. “He led them by a straight way till they reached a city to dwell in” (v. 7).
5. “Let them thank the LORD for his steadfast love, for his wondrous works to the children of men!” (v. 8).
6. “For he satisfies the longing soul, and the hungry soul he fills with good things” (v. 9).

7. “He brought them out of darkness and the shadow of death, and burst their bonds apart” (v. 14).

8. “And let them offer sacrifices of thanksgiving, and tell of his deeds in songs of joy!” (v. 22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is the testimony of the redeemed. The psalm does not tell them to wait until the story is complete. It tells them to say so. A redeemed person has something to say, and the first thing is thanks.

The first story is of wanderers in the desert, hungry and thirsty, who found no city to live in. Think of the caravan from Babylon, traveling over 800 miles to a city that lay in ruins. God “led them by a straight way till they reached a city to dwell in.” Their journey was real, and so was God’s guidance.

The second story is of prisoners in darkness. This is what the exile was. They were captives for rebelling against the words of God. And yet, when they cried out, “he burst their bonds apart.” The third is the sick, who were “fools through their sinful ways.” God’s word healed them.

What is the common thread? Each group was in trouble, each cried out, and each was rescued. Each time the response is the same: “Let them thank the LORD for his steadfast love, for his wondrous works.” The psalm names what the right response is, thanks and sacrifice and songs of joy.

In the setting of the return, thanksgiving was also practical. The altar had been built, and sacrifices of thanksgiving were being offered. Telling of God’s deeds was part of the rebuilding. Remembering and recounting is what keeps the people alive. In the unit’s larger story, Chronicles will do the same on a larger scale, telling the whole history so that the community remembers who they are.

STEP 5

Connection

Colossians 1:13-14 says God “has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son.” Luke 4:18-19: the Spirit anoints him to proclaim liberty to the captives. Ephesians 2:13 says that those who were far off have been brought near. Hebrews 13:15 invites us to offer a sacrifice of praise. 1 Peter 2:9: “that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light.”

STEP 6

Application

Say it out loud: tell one person today what God has redeemed you from.

Write a short thank-you list in the pattern of the psalm: from what you were rescued, how you cried out, and how God answered.

Offer a “sacrifice of thanksgiving” this week, through a gift, a word of praise, or a service.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give thanks to God for gathering you from a far place.

Let your own story say, “The LORD is good,” in your own words.

Thank him that his steadfast love endures forever.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 72

“For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel.”

EZRA 7:10

DAY 502 · WEEK 72

Ezra 7:1-8:36

Ezra arrives; the journey from Babylon to Jerusalem

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezra 7:1-8:36. Fifty-eight years after the temple is finished, Ezra the scribe arrives in Jerusalem. Notice what the text says about his heart in 7:10, and how he organizes the journey in chapter 8.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ezra comes to Jerusalem in 458 BC, in the seventh year of Artaxerxes. He is a priest descended from Aaron and a scribe skilled in the Law of Moses. The temple was built, but the community was spiritually weak, and many were not following the law. The king gave Ezra authority to teach and enforce it. He leads a second group of returning exiles, about 1,800 people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “This Ezra went up from Babylonia. He was a scribe skilled in the Law of Moses” (7:6).
2. “And the king granted him all that he asked, for the hand of the LORD his God was on him” (7:6).
3. “For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel” (7:10).
4. “Blessed be the LORD, the God of our fathers, who put such a thing as this into the heart of the king” (7:27).
5. “I was ashamed to ask the king for a band of soldiers and horsemen to protect us against the enemy on the way” (8:22).

6. “The hand of our God is for good on all who seek him, and the power of his wrath is against all who forsake him” (8:22).
7. “So we fasted and implored our God for this, and he listened to our entreaty” (8:23).
8. “The hand of our God was on us, and he delivered us from the hand of the enemy and from ambushes by the way” (8:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Verse 10 of chapter 7 is among the best descriptions of a teacher of God’s word in the Bible. Ezra “set his heart” to do three things in order: to study the Law of the LORD, to do it, and to teach it. First he studied. Second he practiced. Only then did he teach. The order matters. A teacher who has not studied is shallow. A teacher who has not obeyed is a hypocrite. And study and obedience exist for the sake of sharing.

The phrase “the hand of the LORD his God was on him” appears again and again. Ezra does not take credit. The king’s favor, the safe journey, the gifts and authority all come from God’s hand. The letter from Artaxerxes is remarkable: it commands the treasurers to give whatever Ezra requests for the house of the God of heaven, “lest his wrath be against the realm of the king.” Again, the heart of a Persian king is in God’s hand.

Chapter 8 gives the list of the families and the preparation for the journey. Ezra gathers the people at the river Ahava and discovers that no Levites have come. He sends for them, and they come. Then he does something striking. He is ashamed to ask the king for an armed escort, since he had told the king that “the hand of our God is for good on all who seek him.” Having said it, he proves it. The group fasts and prays for a safe journey. “And he listened to our entreaty.” The caravan carries a fortune in silver, gold, and vessels, and they are not robbed.

The principle is that faith is shown in dependence. Ezra could have asked for soldiers. He chose prayer. He took a risk, the kind that invites God to show who he is.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Timothy 2:15 says, “Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who has no need to be ashamed, rightly handling the word of truth.” James 1:22 says to be doers of the word. Ezekiel 3:1-3 shows the prophet eating the scroll. Ezra’s study, practice, and teaching match Jesus’ pattern (Acts 1:1). Psalm 20:7: “Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God.”

STEP 6

Application

Follow Ezra's order: study something in Scripture this week, apply it, and then share it with someone.

Think about when you reached for "soldiers and horsemen" instead of prayer. What would it look like to depend on God in that area?

Give thanks for those who teach God's word faithfully.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you a heart set to study his law, do it, and teach it.
- Ask him to let his hand be on you for good.
- Tell him where you are trusting him over human protection.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 72

"For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel."

EZRA 7:10

DAY 503 · WEEK 72

Ezra 9:1-10:44

Mixed marriages; covenant faithfulness restored

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 59 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ezra 9:1-10:44. Ezra discovers that many in Israel have married women from the surrounding peoples, who worship other gods. He responds with grief and prayer, and the people respond with repentance. This is a hard passage. Read it carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Soon after Ezra arrives, the leaders report that the people, including priests and Levites, have taken wives from the peoples of the land, adopting their abominations. The concern is not ethnic. The law forbade intermarriage with the Canaanite nations because it would draw Israel into idolatry (Deuteronomy 7:1-4). The same law welcomed foreigners like Rahab and Ruth who came to worship the LORD. The issue here is covenant faithfulness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "As soon as I heard this, I tore my garment and my cloak and pulled hair from my head and beard and sat appalled" (9:3).
2. "O my God, I am ashamed and blush to lift my face to you, my God, for our iniquities have risen higher than our heads" (9:6).
3. "And now, for a brief moment, grace has been shown by the LORD our God, who has left us a remnant" (9:8).
4. "Our God has not forsaken us in our slavery, but has extended to us his steadfast love in the sight of the kings of Persia" (9:9).
5. "O LORD, God of Israel, you are righteous, for we are left a remnant that has escaped, as it is this day" (9:15).

6. “While Ezra prayed and made confession, weeping and casting himself down before the house of God, a very great assembly of men, women, and children gathered” (10:1).
7. “Shecaniah… said to Ezra, We have broken faith with our God… But even now there is hope for Israel in spite of this” (10:2).
8. “Arise, for it is your task, and we are with you; be strong and do it” (10:4).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Ezra’s response is not anger at others. He tears his garment, pulls his hair, and sits appalled until the evening sacrifice. Then he prays on his knees. His prayer is a model. He says “we,” not “they.” He had not married foreign wives himself, but he identifies with the people. He is ashamed. “Our iniquities have risen higher than our heads.” He recalls the history of exile as the result of such sins. And he admits that they have done it again, after all God’s mercy.

The key note is grace. “For a brief moment, grace has been shown by the LORD our God.” Even in the middle of the confession, he acknowledges that being back in the land is itself a gift, “a little reviving in our slavery.” He does not ask for anything. He simply puts himself and the people before the righteous God: “We cannot stand before you because of this.”

The prayer moves the people. A great crowd gathers, weeping. Shecaniah speaks: “We have broken faith with our God… But even now there is hope for Israel in spite of this.” This is the grace of repentance. They propose a covenant to put away the foreign wives and children. It is a painful and controversial decision, and the chapter ends with a long list of names of those who did so. The text does not hide that this was costly and difficult.

We should read this with care. Some readers see in it a harsh ethnic rule. But the text emphasizes the matter of faith: the wives came from idolatrous peoples, and the people of God were in danger of losing their identity as the people who worship the LORD alone. For Christians, the principle is found in 2 Corinthians 6:14-18 and 1 Corinthians 7:12-16, where those already married to unbelievers are told to remain. The heart of the passage is not the specific remedy but the seriousness of repentance and the priority of covenant faithfulness to God.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 9:4-19 shows the same kind of identifying prayer. 1 John 1:9: “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us.” 2 Corinthians 7:10 says godly grief produces repentance that leads to salvation. Ruth, a Moabite, became part of the family of the Messiah by faith (Ruth 4:13-22; Matthew 1:5). Galatians 3:28 says that in Christ there is neither Jew nor Greek. Revelation 7:9 pictures every nation, tribe, people, and language worshiping together.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Ezra's kind of prayer with "we" for your church or community. Confess sins that you share in, even when you were not directly involved.

Ask where your closest alliances and loyalties might draw you away from the LORD.

Receive Shecaniah's words as encouragement: "Even now there is hope."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess in your own words where you are ashamed before God.
- Thank him for being righteous and merciful.
- Ask him to help you turn from what you must leave.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 72

"For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel."

EZRA 7:10

DAY 504 · WEEK 72

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Ezra 7:10 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel."

EZRA 7:10

REST

Meditation

This verse is a summary of a whole life. Ezra's greatness was not in a position but in a heart, and the verse tells us exactly what was in it.

"Ezra had set his heart." To set the heart is a decision, a firm resolve. It did not happen by accident or by drift. It was a choice made on purpose and kept over time. The Hebrew word means to fix or establish. His heart was anchored.

"To study the Law of the LORD." The first thing is study. The word means to seek, to inquire, to dig. Ezra approached Scripture as someone who wanted to know it deeply. He was a scribe, skilled in the Law, but skill was not enough. He studied because he loved it.

"And to do it." The second thing is practice. Knowledge without obedience is empty. Ezra aimed to live what he studied. James 1:22 would later say the same: be doers of the word and not hearers only.

“And to teach his statutes and rules in Israel.” The third thing is teaching. Having studied and obeyed, he shared. His goal was the good of the whole people.

The order here is the pattern for anyone who handles the word of God. You cannot teach what you do not do, and you cannot do what you do not know. If you are a parent, a teacher, a leader in the church, or simply a friend, this verse describes the path. Say it as a prayer: set my heart to study, to do, and to teach.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed the returned exiles through their first sixty years in the land. You read of the foundation of the temple, the opposition that stopped the work, and the prophets who started it again. You saw the temple finished and the Passover kept with joy. You prayed three psalms of return: Psalm 126, the dream of coming home and the hope of sowing in tears; Psalm 85, the prayer for revival; and Psalm 107, the thanks of those redeemed and gathered from the lands. Then you met Ezra, the scribe who set his heart to study, practice, and teach the law of the LORD. You followed him as he prayed for a safe journey, and as he wept over the sin of the people. The week taught that God keeps his word through the hearts of kings, that opposition cannot stop his work, and that repentance and the word of God are the basis of renewal.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Ezra studied, practiced, and then taught. Which of the three is hardest for you right now, and what is one step you could take?

When the work stopped, God sent prophets to encourage the builders. Who has encouraged you in a stalled season, and who might you encourage?

Ezra prayed with “we” and not “they.” What would it look like to confess sin on behalf of your church or community?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to set your heart to study his law and to do it.

Thank him for teachers who have taught you.

Rest in him today.

DAY 505 · WEEK 73

Nehemiah 1:1-2:20

Nehemiah's prayer; commissioned to rebuild the wall

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Nehemiah 1:1-2:20. Nehemiah, a cupbearer to the Persian king, hears that Jerusalem's walls are still broken. Notice that he prays before he speaks, and speaks only after he has prayed for months.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is 445 BC, about thirteen years after Ezra. The temple stands, but Jerusalem has no walls, which leaves it defenseless and shameful. Nehemiah serves in the palace at Susa as cupbearer to Artaxerxes, a trusted position close to the king. A visitor from Judah brings him news of the city's "great trouble and shame." Nehemiah's own memoir fills this book, and it is full of prayer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When I heard these words I sat down and wept and mourned for days, and I continued fasting and praying before the God of heaven" (1:4).
2. "Let your ear be attentive and your eyes open, to hear the prayer of your servant" (1:6).
3. "Both I and my father's house have sinned" (1:6).
4. "Remember the word that you commanded your servant Moses" (1:8).
5. "Then the king said to me, What are you requesting? So I prayed to the God of heaven" (2:4).
6. "And the king granted me what I asked, for the good hand of my God was upon me" (2:8).
7. "Let us rise up and build. So they strengthened their hands for the good work" (2:18).

8 “The God of heaven will make us prosper, and we his servants will arise and build” (2:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Nehemiah’s first response to bad news is tears and prayer. He does not rush to a plan. For about four months, from Chislev to Nisan, he fasts and prays. His prayer follows the pattern of Daniel 9 and Ezra 9: he praises God for his covenant love, confesses sins including his own and his father’s house, remembers the promise of Moses to gather the scattered, and asks for success before the king.

Then comes the moment. The king notices that his cupbearer is sad, which is dangerous, since sadness in the royal presence could cost a man his life. “Then I was very much afraid.” The king asks what he wants. Nehemiah does something wonderful: “So I prayed to the God of heaven.” In the span of a breath, between the king’s question and his own answer, he sends up a prayer. Then he answers boldly and specifically. He asks for time, letters of safe passage, and timber. All of it is given, “for the good hand of my God was upon me.”

Nehemiah arrives in Jerusalem and quietly inspects the walls at night. Only then does he tell the leaders about the vision God gave him. His appeal ties the work to what God has already done: “I told them how the hand of my God had been upon me for good.” They answer, “Let us rise up and build.”

Opposition appears at once, in the form of Sanballat, Tobiah, and Geshem, who mock and accuse. Nehemiah’s reply is calm: “The God of heaven will make us prosper.” He does not argue or defend himself. He states whose work it is.

The pattern is prayer, planning, and perseverance. Prayer came first and was sustained. Planning followed, with specific requests and a night survey. Then came bold action.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus told his disciples to pray and not lose heart (Luke 18:1). Philippians 4:6 says, “In everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God.” James 1:5 promises wisdom to those who ask. Proverbs 21:1 says the king’s heart is a stream of water in the hand of the LORD. Colossians 4:2-3 asks us to continue steadfastly in prayer. Luke 14:28 teaches counting the cost before building.

STEP 6

Application

Practice the “arrow prayer” today: breathe a quick prayer before a hard conversation or decision.

Name a broken wall in your family, church, or community that burdens you. Pray about it for a week before you act.

Confess sins you share in, as Nehemiah did, and then ask God for his good hand.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Pray as Nehemiah did: praise God, confess your sin and your people’s, and name what burdens you.

Ask him to let his ear be attentive.

Tell him what you are asking him for.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 73

“Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.”

NEHEMIAH 8:10

DAY 506 · WEEK 73

Nehemiah 3:1-4:23

The wall rebuilt; opposition from without

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 55 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Nehemiah 3:1-4:23. A long list of names builds the wall, and then opposition turns to ridicule and threat. Notice how Nehemiah answers both.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 3 is a work roster. Priests, goldsmiths, perfumers, rulers, daughters, and merchants each repair a section, often opposite their own homes. Chapter 4 shows the enemy's reaction: mockery, a plot to attack, and discouragement from within Judah itself. The wall is half built when the strain begins to tell.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Next to him Zadok the son of Baana repaired. Next to him the Tekoites repaired" (3:4-5).
2. "but their nobles would not stoop to serve their Lords" (3:5).
3. "Next to him Shallum... repaired, he and his daughters" (3:12).
4. "What are these feeble Jews doing?" (4:2).
5. "Hear, O our God, for we are despised" (4:4).
6. "So we built the wall... for the people had a mind to work" (4:6).
7. "And we prayed to our God and set a guard as a protection against them day and night" (4:9).
8. "Do not be afraid of them. Remember the Lord, who is great and awesome, and fight for your brothers" (4:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 3 may look like dull reading, but it carries a point. Everyone had a place. The high priest rebuilt a gate. Goldsmiths and perfumers, who knew nothing of masonry, took up stone. A man named Shallum "and his daughters" worked together. People repaired the part nearest their own houses, so that the protection of the wall mattered to them personally. The wall was a community project.

There is also a note of sadness: "the nobles of the Tekoites would not stoop to serve their Lord." God records the names of those who work and he also notes who did not. Yet the Tekoites, ordinary families, repaired two sections.

Chapter 4 shows the opposition growing. First comes ridicule: "Even what they are building, if a fox goes up on it he will break down their stone wall!" Nehemiah's response is to pray and keep building. He does not retaliate. He simply asks God to hear. "So we built the wall... for the people had a mind to work."

Then comes the threat. The enemy plans to attack, and Judah itself is discouraged: "The strength of those who carry the burdens is failing, and there is much rubbish." Their weariness is honest. Nehemiah answers with a double strategy: "We prayed to our God and set a guard." Faith and wisdom work together. He then arms families by sections and speaks the words that settle them: "Remember the Lord, who is great and awesome." Fear shrinks when God is seen as big.

The chapter ends with workers holding a trowel in one hand and a weapon in the other, sleeping in their clothes. "Our God will fight for us." It was hard, and it was done together.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Corinthians 12:12-27 describes the church as one body with many members, each needed. Ephesians 4:16 says the whole body is "joined and held together by every joint." Ephesians 6:10-18 speaks of the armor of God. Matthew 26:41 says to watch and pray. 2 Corinthians 10:4 says the weapons of our warfare are not worldly. Exodus 14:14: "The LORD will fight for you."

STEP 6

Application

Find your "section of the wall." What is nearest to your own house that you can repair or serve?

When criticized, try Nehemiah's response: pray briefly, and keep working.

Thank someone whose steady, unnoticed work holds up your community.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God for a place in his work beside others.
- Tell him what mockery or discouragement you face.
- Ask him to strengthen your hands.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 73

“Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.”

NEHEMIAH 8:10

DAY 507 · WEEK 73

Nehemiah 5:1-7:73

Social justice; the wall completed; the exiles registered

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 107 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Nehemiah 5:1-7:73. A crisis arises inside the community, and Nehemiah rebukes the wealthy for exploiting the poor. Then the enemies change tactics. The wall is finished in fifty-two days.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

While the wall is rising, a cry goes up from the poor. Famine, taxes, and debt have driven them to mortgage their fields and sell their children into slavery to their own countrymen. This is a problem more dangerous than any external enemy. Nehemiah also faces personal schemes to distract and frighten him, but the wall is finished in the month of Elul.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “There was a great outcry of the people and of their wives against their Jewish brothers” (5:1).
2. “I was very angry when I heard their outcry” (5:6).
3. “I consulted with myself, and I brought charges against the nobles” (5:7).
4. “The thing that you are doing is not good. Ought you not to walk in the fear of our God?” (5:9).
5. “Out of reverence for God I did not do so” (5:15).
6. “Come and let us meet together... But they intended to do me harm” (6:2).
7. “I am doing a great work and I cannot come down” (6:3).
8. “So the wall was finished on the twenty-fifth day of the month Elul, in fifty-two days” (6:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The hardest challenge to the wall came from within. The poor were crushed by debt, and some of the rich were profiting from their brothers' misery. This was exactly what the law of Moses forbade (Exodus 22:25, Leviticus 25:35-37). Nehemiah is furious, yet notice what he does: he "consulted with myself," meaning he took time to think before he acted. Then he called a great assembly and made his case on the basis of the fear of God and the witness to the nations. The nobles repent and give back the fields and interest. Nehemiah then points to his own example. As governor, he refused the food allowance due to him, because "the service was too heavy on the people." He led with his own life.

Then the enemy changes tactics. Four times they invite him to a meeting, planning to harm him. Nehemiah's answer is a classic: "I am doing a great work and I cannot come down." He knew his calling and would not be pulled off it. The enemy tries a false accusation, then a hired prophet who tries to scare him into hiding in the temple. Nehemiah sees through it: "Should such a man as I run away?" He discerned that the prophet was bribed. Then he prays: "Now, O God, strengthen my hands."

And the wall is finished in fifty-two days. Even the enemies recognize "this work had been accomplished with the help of our God." But the end of chapter 6 shows that trouble remains: Tobiah keeps sending letters. Chapter 7 sets up the next task, which is to repopulate the city and put people back in order.

STEP 5

Connection

James 5:1-6 condemns those who defraud their workers. Luke 3:11 and Acts 4:34-35 describe sharing with those in need. 1 Peter 5:2-3 calls leaders to serve as examples. Luke 9:51 says Jesus set his face toward Jerusalem. Philippians 3:13-14: "one thing I do: forgetting what lies behind… I press on." Galatians 6:2: bear one another's burdens.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether there is anyone you could help who is burdened by debt or need. Act on it.

Think of your "great work." What distractions do you need to say "I cannot come down" to?

Lead by example in one area where others look to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God for the fear of him that treats others justly.

Ask him to keep you from taking advantage of the poor.

Thank him for the finished work.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 73

“Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.”

NEHEMIAH 8:10

DAY 508 · WEEK 73

Psalm 147

Praise the LORD who rebuilds Jerusalem

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 147. Imagine the people standing before the finished wall. Notice who builds, who gathers, and who counts.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 147 is one of the five "Hallelujah" psalms that close the Psalter. Verse 2 reads, "The LORD builds up Jerusalem; he gathers the outcasts of Israel." Many readers connect it to the dedication of the wall in Nehemiah 12. Whether or not it was written for that day, it fits perfectly. It praises the God who builds cities, heals the brokenhearted, counts the stars, and feeds the animals.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! For it is good to sing praises to our God" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD builds up Jerusalem; he gathers the outcasts of Israel" (v. 2).
3. "He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds" (v. 3).
4. "He determines the number of the stars; he gives to all of them their names" (v. 4).
5. "Great is our Lord, and abundant in power; his understanding is beyond measure" (v. 5).
6. "The LORD lifts up the humble; he casts the wicked to the ground" (v. 6).
7. "His delight is not in the strength of the horse, nor his pleasure in the legs of a man" (v. 10).
8. "He declares his word to Jacob, his statutes and rules to Israel" (v. 19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm gives us a surprising list of what God does, all in the same breath. He builds Jerusalem. He gathers outcasts. He heals the brokenhearted and binds their wounds. And he counts and names every star. The same God who handles the vastness of the cosmos kneels to bandage a wound. There is no contradiction: greatness and tenderness belong together.

This is a good word for a people who had just finished a wall. The wall was built by Nehemiah and the workers, and yet "the LORD builds up Jerusalem." Our work is real, and God is the true builder (Psalm 127:1).

Verse 6 declares God's character: he lifts the humble and casts down the wicked. Verses 7 to 9 move to creation: rain on the earth, grass on the hills, food for the beasts and for the young ravens when they cry. God provides for the ravens. If he cares for them, he cares for his people.

Then verse 10 draws a line. He does not delight in the strength of the horse or the legs of a man. He takes pleasure "in those who fear him, in those who hope in his steadfast love." God is not impressed by human power. He is moved by humble trust.

The psalm ends with the word: God has given his statutes to Israel. "He has not dealt thus with any other nation." The greatest gift is not military strength or good weather but a God who speaks. The word is what makes the people a people.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 4:18 shows Jesus proclaiming healing for the brokenhearted and release for captives. Matthew 6:26 says the Father feeds the birds of the air. Matthew 10:29-31 teaches that he knows the sparrows and the hairs of our heads. John 10:3 says the shepherd calls his own sheep by name. Isaiah 40:26 also speaks of the God who calls the stars by name. John 1:1: In the beginning was the Word.

STEP 6

Application

Go outside tonight and look at the sky. Thank the God who named the stars and also knows your name.

Name a brokenhearted person you know. Ask God how you might be part of binding up their wounds.

Praise God aloud for his word, which he has given to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for rebuilding what is broken.

Thank him that he heals the brokenhearted.

Tell him what has been healed in you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 73

“Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.”

NEHEMIAH 8:10

DAY 509 · WEEK 73

Psalm 148

Praise the LORD from the heavens

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 148. This psalm calls every part of creation to praise: heavens, deeps, weather, mountains, animals, kings, and children. Read it aloud as a roll call.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 148 is a hymn that commands praise from everything God has made. It is structured in two halves: praise from the heavens (vv. 1-6) and praise from the earth (vv. 7-14). You will read this psalm again in Unit 24. Today, read it as the response of the rebuilt city, standing on a wall whose stones, towers, and gates lie under the open sky.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Praise the LORD from the heavens; praise him in the heights!” (v. 1).
2. “Praise him, all his angels; praise him, all his hosts!” (v. 2).
3. “Praise him, sun and moon, praise him, all you shining stars!” (v. 3).
4. “Let them praise the name of the LORD! For he commanded and they were created” (v. 5).
5. “Praise the LORD from the earth, you great sea creatures and all deeps” (v. 7).
6. “Fire and hail, snow and mist, stormy wind fulfilling his word!” (v. 8).
7. “Kings of the earth and all peoples, princes and all rulers of the earth! Young men and maidens together, old men and children!” (vv. 11-12).
8. “He has raised up a horn for his people, praise for all his saints” (v. 14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a vast choir. First the heavens: angels, hosts, sun, moon, stars, even "you waters above the heavens." They praise because "he commanded and they were created." Creation did not come from chance or from rival gods but from a spoken word. Everything in the sky exists by the will of God and is meant to bring him glory.

Then the earth: sea creatures, fire, hail, snow, stormy winds, mountains, fruit trees, cattle, creeping things, and flying birds. Notice the wildness. The deeps and the storms are not enemies of praise; even "stormy wind fulfilling his word." The elements that frightened ancient people are in the choir. Creation praises by being what God made it to be.

Finally comes humanity: kings and peoples, young and old, men and women. Everyone, from the throne to the cradle, is summoned. Humans praise with words and wills, which the rest of creation cannot do. We give voice to the whole choir.

The reason for praise is that "his name alone is exalted; his majesty is above earth and heaven." And then a surprising turn: "He has raised up a horn for his people." The God of galaxies takes special notice of a small people. A horn meant strength and a ruler. For a community just rebuilt, it carried the hope of a coming king.

For you, the point is that praise is not a private act that fits in the margins. It is the purpose of everything that exists. When you praise, you join a choir that is as old as creation.

STEP 5

Connection

Colossians 1:16 says all things were created through him and for him. Romans 8:19-22 says creation waits and groans for the revealing of the sons of God. Luke 1:69 says God "has raised up a horn of salvation for us in the house of his servant David." Philippians 2:10 says every knee will bow. Revelation 5:13 hears every creature in heaven and earth and under the earth and in the sea saying, "To him who sits on the throne and to the Lamb be blessing."

STEP 6

Application

Spend ten minutes outdoors. Name five things you see and thank God for each.

Praise God with your whole voice today, by singing or speaking aloud.

Notice how everything around you was commanded into being by God's word.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Join creation in praising God, naming what in creation moves you.
- Thank him that he commanded and you were created.
- Praise him for raising up a horn for his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 73

“Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.”

NEHEMIAH 8:10

DAY 510 · WEEK 73

Nehemiah 8:1-10:39

The law read; the Feast of Booths; covenant renewal

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 92 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Nehemiah 8:1-10:39. The people gather in the square and ask Ezra to read the Book of the Law. They stand, listen for hours, weep, and then are told to rejoice. They confess their sins and sign a covenant. Read it as the high point of the book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The wall is done, and the people settle in their towns. In the seventh month, at the Feast of Trumpets, they gather “as one man” in the square before the Water Gate. They have not been summoned by a king. They ask for the Book. This is a revival driven by the word of God. It is the only time in the Bible that we see an entire congregation hear the law and respond with weeping, joy, confession, and covenant renewal.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “And all the people gathered as one man into the square” (8:1).
2. “And Ezra opened the book in the sight of all the people… and as he opened it all the people stood” (8:5).
3. “They read from the book, from the Law of God, clearly, and they gave the sense, so that the people understood the reading” (8:8).
4. “For all the people wept as they heard the words of the Law” (8:9).
5. “Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength” (8:10).
6. “And there was very great rejoicing” (8:17).
7. “You are the LORD, you alone. You have made heaven” (9:6).

8 “But you are a God ready to forgive, gracious and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love” (9:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is a scene of a people hungry for the word. Ezra stands on a wooden platform and reads from early morning until midday. Others “gave the sense” so everyone could understand. This is the pattern of faithful preaching: read the text, explain it, and apply it. The people stand, say “Amen, Amen,” lift their hands, and bow. The word was not a lecture but an encounter.

Then they weep. The law had convicted them of how far they had drifted. But the leaders say, “This day is holy to the LORD your God; do not mourn or weep.” The word does not leave them in grief. “Go your way, eat the fat and drink sweet wine… for the joy of the LORD is your strength.” The joy here is not their own mood. It is God’s joy in them, and it is a source of strength. Godly sorrow leads to joy.

They discover the Feast of Booths and keep it with great gladness. For the first time since Joshua, they build and live in booths. Then they gather again to confess. Chapter 9 contains one of the longest prayers in the Bible, a sweeping retelling of history from creation to the present. It praises God for faithfulness and confesses Israel’s repeated rebellion. The refrain is that God was “ready to forgive, gracious and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love,” and he did not forsake them. It ends with honesty: “Behold, we are slaves this day… in the land that you gave.” The return is real and still incomplete.

Chapter 10 records their response: a written covenant, signed by leaders. They promise to walk in God’s law, to avoid mixed marriages, to keep the Sabbath, to support the temple, and to bring the firstfruits. “We will not neglect the house of our God.”

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 119:105: “Your word is a lamp to my feet.” Luke 24:32: “Did not our hearts burn within us while he talked to us on the road?” Romans 10:17: “Faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ.” John 15:11: “that my joy may be in you, and that your joy may be full.” 2 Timothy 4:2 says to preach the word. Hebrews 12:2: “for the joy that was set before him.”

STEP 6

Application

Set aside time this week to read Scripture aloud, perhaps a whole chapter.

Ask what you could do to help others understand the word. “Give the sense” to someone younger in the faith.

When conviction comes, listen for the second sentence: “The joy of the LORD is your strength.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you a hunger for his word.
- Ask him to turn your weeping into joy when his word convicts you.
- Thank him that the joy of the LORD is your strength.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 73

“Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.”

NEHEMIAH 8:10

DAY 511 · WEEK 73

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Nehemiah 8:10 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength."

NEHEMIAH 8:10

REST

Meditation

This verse was spoken to a crowd in tears. They had just heard God's law read aloud, and the weight of their failure came crashing down. The leaders did not tell them their sorrow was wrong. They told them where it should lead.

"Do not be grieved." The command is not to deny sorrow. It is to refuse to stay in it. Grief that leaves us stuck is not the grief God wants. 2 Corinthians 7:10 says that godly grief leads to repentance, and repentance leads to life. The next step after sorrow is not more sorrow. It is joy.

"For the joy of the LORD." Whose joy is it? It is the LORD's joy. Not merely the joy the people have in him, though that is included. It is the joy God himself has: in his creation, in his people, in forgiving. Zephaniah 3:17 says he rejoices over us with gladness. This day was a feast day, and their Father was glad to have them home.

“Is your strength.” The word means a stronghold, a refuge. When your joy depends on circumstances, it can be taken. When it rests in God’s own delight, it holds. The people were facing opposition, poverty, and an uncertain future. They needed a strength that did not depend on any of that.

Say this verse when you feel heavy with guilt or weariness. Let it turn your face from yourself to God. He has not given up on you. He is glad to forgive, and his gladness is where you find strength.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you walked with Nehemiah from a palace in Susa to the walls of Jerusalem. You watched him pray for four months, then pray again in a breath before the king. You saw ordinary people repair the wall in front of their own houses, and you saw the enemy change tactics from ridicule to threat to flattery to fear. You saw Nehemiah rebuke the nobles for oppressing the poor and refuse to come down from his great work. The wall was finished in fifty-two days. In Psalm 147 and Psalm 148, you heard God praised as the builder of Jerusalem, healer of the brokenhearted, namer of the stars, and the one whose name every creature is called to praise. At the end of the week, the people gathered at the Water Gate, listened to the word of God for hours, wept, were told to rejoice, kept the Feast of Booths, confessed their sins, and signed a covenant.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Nehemiah prayed for months and also sent up quick prayers in the moment. How might you practice both kinds of prayer this week?

The returned exiles wept at the law and were told to rejoice. How does the gospel of Jesus Christ turn conviction into joy?

The wall was built by many hands, each near their own house. Where is your section of the wall, and who is working beside you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his joy is your strength.

Thank him for a word that convicts and comforts.

Rest in him.

DAY 512 · WEEK 74

Nehemiah 11:1-13:31

Jerusalem populated; the wall dedicated; final reforms

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 108 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Nehemiah 11:1-13:31. The city is repopulated and the wall is dedicated with two great choirs. Then Nehemiah returns from a trip to Susa and finds that the people have already slipped back into old sins. Notice the ending.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 11 lists those who settled in Jerusalem, chosen by lot to bring one in ten from the towns. Chapter 12 describes the joyful dedication of the wall. Chapter 13 jumps ahead, probably about 432 BC. Nehemiah had returned to Persia for a time. When he comes back, he finds that Tobiah has been given a room in the temple, the Levites are unpaid, the Sabbath is being broken, and some have married foreign wives again.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “And the people blessed all the men who willingly offered to live in Jerusalem” (11:2).
2. “And at the dedication of the wall of Jerusalem they sought the Levites… to celebrate the dedication with gladness” (12:27).
3. “And I brought the leaders of Judah up onto the wall, and appointed two great choirs that gave thanks” (12:31).
4. “And they offered great sacrifices that day and rejoiced, for God had made them rejoice with great joy” (12:43).
5. “And the sound of the joy of Jerusalem was heard far away” (12:43).
6. “And I was very angry, and I threw all the household furniture of Tobiah out of the chamber” (13:8).

7. “Why is the house of God forsaken?” (13:11).
8. “Remember me, O my God, for good” (13:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The dedication of the wall is a high point. Two great choirs and processions go around the wall in opposite directions, singing, with cymbals, harps, and lyres, and meet at the temple. The people offer sacrifices, and “God had made them rejoice with great joy.” Women and children rejoice too. The sound of Jerusalem’s joy is heard far away. This recalls the sound at the foundation of the temple in Ezra 3, but now it is clearly joy, without the weeping.

And then chapter 13 is a sober coda. Nehemiah returns and finds the covenant broken. Tobiah, the enemy who had mocked the builders, now lives in a storeroom of the temple. The Levites have gone back to their farms because no one paid them. The Sabbath markets are in full swing. Some have married foreign wives. Nehemiah’s reaction is fierce. He throws out Tobiah’s furniture, restores the tithes, shuts the gates on the Sabbath, and rebukes those who intermarried.

The lesson is plain. Reform does not last on its own. A wall can be built in fifty-two days, a covenant can be signed in a day, but the human heart drifts back. Even after confession and revival, the people forgot. This is why the Old Testament ends not with triumph but with a longing for something deeper. The law written on stone and walls built of stone cannot change the heart.

Nehemiah ends with a prayer: “Remember me, O my God, for good.” It is the prayer of a faithful servant who knows that his work is not finished. The book closes with unresolved tension: God’s people are back, but they need a better covenant. The new covenant promised in Jeremiah 31 and Ezekiel 36 is still ahead.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 31:33 promises a law written on the heart. Hebrews 8:6-13 says Jesus mediates a better covenant. Ezekiel 36:26: “I will give you a new heart.” Galatians 3:3 asks, “Are you so foolish? Having begun by the Spirit, are you now being perfected by the flesh?” Revelation 2:4 warns about leaving our first love. 1 Corinthians 10:12: “Let anyone who thinks that he stands take heed lest he fall.”

STEP 6

Application

Think about a reform in your life that has slipped. What helps a good change last?

Be humble about your own heart. Ask a trusted friend to check on you in an area of past failure.

Thank God that the new covenant does not depend on our consistency but on Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the joy of those who worship him.

Ask him to keep you from drifting back.

Ask him to write his law on your heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 74

"And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?"

ESTHER 4:14

DAY 513 · WEEK 74

Esther 1:1-3:15

Esther becomes queen; Haman's plot

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Esther 1:1-3:15. A Persian king deposes his queen, a Jewish orphan becomes queen, and a proud official plots to destroy the Jews. Notice what is missing from the book: God's name is never mentioned.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Esther is set in Susa, the Persian capital, around 483 to 473 BC, between the first return under Zerubbabel and the return under Ezra. Most Jews had stayed in the empire. The book is a story of those who remained scattered. It never names God, never mentions prayer except fasting, and yet shows his hand everywhere. The theme is "God unseen but sovereign."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In those days, when King Ahasuerus sat on his royal throne in Susa, the citadel" (1:2).
2. "For the queen's behavior will become known to all women" (1:17).
3. "Mordecai… had taken her as his own daughter" (2:7).
4. "Esther had not made known her people or kindred, for Mordecai had commanded her" (2:10).
5. "And the king loved Esther more than all the women" (2:17).
6. "Mordecai told them that he was a Jew" (3:4).
7. "Haman… sought to destroy all the Jews, the people of Mordecai, throughout the whole kingdom of Ahasuerus" (3:6).
8. "And the king and Haman sat down to drink, but the city of Susa was thrown into confusion" (3:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is a story full of coincidences. The queen refuses to appear, so she is replaced, and a Jewish orphan girl is chosen. Her cousin Mordecai happens to overhear a plot against the king and reports it, and the deed is written in the chronicles. Haman is promoted. Mordecai refuses to bow, and Haman's pride turns his anger against a whole people. He casts lots, called "pur," to choose the day of destruction, and the lot falls on a date eleven months away.

The author never says "God did this." Yet the reader sees a pattern: nothing is an accident. The Hebrew Bible keeps the name of God out of the text, but his purposes steer every scene. This is a book for people who live in a world where God seems silent. Most Jews of that age lived under pagan rule, far from the temple, with no prophet, no miracle, no visible sign. Esther says that God is still working.

There is a deeper background. Haman is an Agagite, a descendant of Agag, king of the Amalekites (1 Samuel 15). Mordecai is from the line of Kish, Saul's father. The old conflict between Israel and Amalek, which Saul failed to finish, is reborn. The enemy of God's people tries again to wipe them out. The question is whether God's promise to Abraham, to bless the nations through his seed, will survive.

The edict goes out, and the chapter ends with an ugly picture: the king and Haman sit down to drink while the city is in confusion. The powerful feast while the powerless tremble.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:28 says that God works all things together for good. Genesis 50:20: "You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good." Proverbs 16:33: "The lot is cast into the lap, but its every decision is from the LORD." Exodus 17:14-16 is the LORD's war against Amalek. Psalm 121:4: he who keeps Israel will neither slumber nor sleep.

STEP 6

Application

Where do you feel that God is silent in your life? Ask God to open your eyes to his unseen hand.

Look back at one "coincidence" in your story and thank God for it.

Pray for believers living under hostile or indifferent governments.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he rules even when his name is not spoken.

Ask him to open your eyes to his hand in your circumstances.

Tell him what feels like an accident in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 74

“And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?”

ESTHER 4:14

DAY 514 · WEEK 74

Esther 4:1-7:10

"For such a time as this"; the king's banquet; Haman exposed

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Esther 4:1-7:10. Esther is called to risk her life for her people. Read for the turning point in 4:14, and for the reversal at the end of chapter 7.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

When Mordecai learns of the decree, he puts on sackcloth and ashes and weeps in the city. Esther, in the palace, hears of it. Anyone who approaches the king unsummoned may be put to death, unless the king holds out the golden scepter. Esther has not been called in thirty days. Mordecai's message to her is one of the great speeches of the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And in every province… there was great mourning among the Jews, with fasting and weeping and lamenting" (4:3).
2. "For if you keep silent at this time, relief and deliverance will rise for the Jews from another place, but you and your father's house will perish" (4:14).
3. "And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?" (4:14).
4. "Go, gather all the Jews to be found in Susa, and hold a fast on my behalf" (4:16).
5. "And if I perish, I perish" (4:16).
6. "On that night the king could not sleep. And he gave orders to bring the book of memorable deeds" (6:1).
7. "What honor or dignity has been bestowed on Mordecai for this?" (6:3).
8. "So they hanged Haman on the gallows that he had prepared for Mordecai" (7:10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Mordecai's message is the heart of the book. He makes two points. First, Esther cannot hide in the palace: "Do not think to yourself that in the king's palace you will escape." Second, God's purpose does not depend on her. "Relief and deliverance will rise for the Jews from another place." This is as close as the book comes to naming God. Then comes the question: "Who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?" It is a call to see one's position as a calling.

Esther's response grows from fear to courage. She asks for a three-day fast, which means prayer in all but name, and says, "If I perish, I perish." She will go to the king, trusting not in her beauty but in God. When she enters, the king holds out the scepter. She does not blurt out her request. She invites the king and Haman to a banquet, then to a second one. This is not hesitation but wisdom.

Meanwhile, the narrative shifts to a sleepless night. The king "could not sleep," and so he calls for the chronicles. They open to the record of Mordecai's good deed. The ironies multiply. Haman, who has just come to ask permission to hang Mordecai, is asked what should be done for the man the king delights to honor. Thinking it is himself, he proposes royal robes and a parade, and then must lead Mordecai through the streets.

At the second banquet, Esther names her request: "Let my life be granted me, and my people." Haman is exposed, and the gallows he built for Mordecai becomes his own. "Sleeplessness" in the ordinary world is a vehicle for providence.

STEP 5

Connection

Moses faced the same choice in Hebrews 11:24-26, giving up Pharaoh's palace to be mistreated with the people of God. Jesus said, "Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends" (John 15:13). Psalm 7:15-16 and Proverbs 26:27 describe the trap that falls on the one who set it. Acts 17:26 says God determined the allotted periods of nations. 1 Peter 4:10: use your gifts to serve others.

STEP 6

Application

Ask: for what "such a time as this" might God have put you where you are?

Fast and pray before a major decision, as Esther and the Jews did.

Notice the people God has placed in your path, and be ready to speak up for them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to show you what purpose he has put you where you are.

Ask for courage to speak when it costs you.

Ask for wisdom in choosing the right moment.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 74

"And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?"

ESTHER 4:14

DAY 515 · WEEK 74

Esther 8:1-10:3

The reversal; deliverance; Purim, God unseen but sovereign

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Esther 8:1-10:3. The decree is reversed, the Jews defend themselves, and the festival of Purim is established. Read for the language of reversal.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Haman is dead, but the first decree, written in the king's name, cannot be revoked under Persian law. Esther and Mordecai are authorized to write a second decree, allowing the Jews to defend themselves on the appointed day. The book ends with the establishment of the festival of Purim, still celebrated by Jews today, and a brief note on Mordecai's greatness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "On that day King Ahasuerus gave to Queen Esther the house of Haman" (8:1).
2. "And Mordecai… was set over the house of Haman" (8:2).
3. "For how can I bear to see the calamity that is coming to my people?" (8:6).
4. "The Jews had light and gladness and joy and honor" (8:16).
5. "And many from the peoples of the country declared themselves Jews, for fear of the Jews had fallen on them" (8:17).
6. "On the very day when the enemies of the Jews hoped to gain mastery over them, the reverse occurred" (9:1).
7. "As the days on which the Jews got relief from their enemies, and as the month that had been turned for them from sorrow into gladness" (9:22).
8. "For Mordecai the Jew was second in rank to King Ahasuerus… seeking the welfare of his people and speaking peace to all his people" (10:3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The second half of the book is a great reversal. What was meant for evil is turned to good. The day appointed for the destruction of the Jews becomes a day of their deliverance. The man who sought the throne's favor hangs on his own gallows. The man who would have been executed wears the king's ring. Mourning becomes feasting. Fear falls on the enemies.

The Jews are allowed to defend themselves, which they do. The text insists that they "laid no hand on the plunder," emphasizing that they were not seeking gain, in contrast to the Amalekite conflict where Saul kept the spoil. This time, the enemy of God's people is finished, and the people do what Saul failed to do.

Purim, from "pur," the lot, is established as a perennial reminder. "The month that had been turned for them from sorrow into gladness." The feast would include sending gifts to one another and to the poor. The memory of deliverance becomes an act of generosity.

Why is God never named? Many see a theological point. The book is written for the diaspora, the Jews who stayed behind. They would have to live by faith without temple or prophet. Esther shows them that God's providence is not limited to Jerusalem. He works through palaces, sleepless nights, banquets, and edicts. He keeps his promise to preserve the line of Abraham, through which the Messiah would come. The Jewish people cannot be wiped out, because the seed of the woman must come.

The last verse describes Mordecai as one who "sought the welfare of his people and spoke peace to all his people." It is a picture of faithful service in a foreign court, much like Joseph and Daniel before him.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:31: "If God is for us, who can be against us?" Isaiah 61:3 promises a garland instead of ashes. John 16:20: "Your sorrow will turn into joy." Psalm 30:11: "You have turned for me my mourning into dancing." Jeremiah 29:7 told the exiles to seek the welfare of the city. Galatians 4:4: "But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son." The preservation of the Jews led to the birth of Jesus.

STEP 6

Application

Think about a situation that seems hopeless. Ask God for the "reversal" he can bring.

Practice the spirit of Purim: send a gift to a friend and to someone in need.

Seek the welfare of your city or workplace, as Mordecai did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for turning sorrow into gladness.
- Thank him for preserving his people when his name is unseen.
- Ask him to make you glad and generous.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 74

"And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?"

ESTHER 4:14

DAY 516 · WEEK 74

Psalm 145

I will extol you, my God and King

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 145. This is the last psalm of David in the Psalter, and the only one labeled "A Praise." Read it as a response to the book of Esther, which never mentions God, by a psalm that does nothing else.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 145 is an acrostic, with each verse beginning with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet, covering praise from A to Z. It sets the tone for the final five psalms, which are full of hallelujahs. After reading Esther, where God's name is hidden, Psalm 145 shows that God's character is plain: he is great, good, near, and faithful.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will extol you, my God and King, and bless your name forever and ever" (v. 1).
2. "Great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised, and his greatness is unsearchable" (v. 3).
3. "One generation shall commend your works to another, and shall declare your mighty acts" (v. 4).
4. "The LORD is gracious and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love" (v. 8).
5. "The LORD is good to all, and his mercy is over all that he has made" (v. 9).
6. "Your kingdom is an everlasting kingdom, and your dominion endures throughout all generations" (v. 13).
7. "The eyes of all look to you, and you give them their food in due season" (v. 15).
8. "The LORD is near to all who call on him, to all who call on him in truth" (v. 18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a sustained song of delight in God. David starts with a personal vow to praise every day, forever. But his praise is not private. “One generation shall commend your works to another.” The faith is passed along by telling.

The center of the psalm is verse 8, which echoes God’s self-revelation to Moses in Exodus 34:6: “gracious and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love.” This phrase recurs throughout the Old Testament as the summary of God’s character. You have met it in Nehemiah 9 and will find it in Joel and Jonah. David builds on it: God is good to all, and his mercy is over all he has made.

The psalm then celebrates his kingdom, which is everlasting. Human kingdoms rise and fall: Babylon, Persia, and so on. But God’s reign does not end. And yet this great King is near. He upholds all who are falling, raises those who are bowed down, and opens his hand to satisfy the desire of every living thing.

Verses 17 to 20 speak about God’s nearness and justice. “The LORD is near to all who call on him in truth. He fulfills the desire of those who fear him; he also hears their cry and saves them.” This is the answer for the diaspora. Even when God’s name is not on the page, he is near.

The psalm ends with the promise that the wicked will be destroyed, and the call for all flesh to bless his holy name forever. There is a stunning phrase in the Hebrew Bible: there is no verse starting with the letter “nun” in the standard Hebrew text, though some ancient copies have one. Even the most careful praise is not complete; there is always more to say.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 34:6-7 is the source of the phrase in verse 8. Matthew 5:45 says that God makes his sun rise on the evil and the good. Matthew 6:33 promises that those who seek first the kingdom will be provided for. Luke 1:33 says of Jesus, “Of his kingdom there will be no end.” James 4:8: “Draw near to God, and he will draw near to you.” Revelation 4:11 praises the Lord for creating all things.

STEP 6

Application

Read the psalm aloud as your morning praise. Let each verse draw you into worship.

Tell a younger person about something God has done for you. “One generation shall commend your works to another.”

Memorize verse 18, and pray it when you feel far from God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Extol God as King, in your own words.
- Tell him one thing he has done that you want to commend to another generation.
- Thank him that he is near to all who call on him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 74

"And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?"

ESTHER 4:14

DAY 517 · WEEK 74

Psalm 149; Psalm 150

Sing a new song; let everything that has breath praise

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 16 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalms 149 and 150. These are the final two psalms in the Psalter, and they close the book with praise. You will read them again in Unit 24. Read them now as the response to Esther's deliverance and the dedication of the wall.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 149 calls the people to sing a new song, with dancing and with a two-edged sword in hand. Psalm 150 is the grand finale, naming where, why, and with what to praise God. The Psalter began with Psalm 1, the blessed man who meditates on the law. It ends with every breath praising the LORD.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Sing to the LORD a new song, his praise in the assembly of the godly!" (149:1).
2. "Let Israel be glad in his Maker; let the children of Zion rejoice in their King!" (149:2).
3. "For the LORD takes pleasure in his people; he adorns the humble with salvation" (149:4).
4. "Let the high praises of God be in their throats and two-edged swords in their hands" (149:6).
5. "This is honor for all his godly ones. Praise the LORD!" (149:9).
6. "Praise God in his sanctuary; praise him in his mighty heavens!" (150:1).
7. "Praise him for his mighty deeds; praise him according to his excellent greatness!" (150:2).
8. "Let everything that has breath praise the LORD! Praise the LORD!" (150:6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 149 begins with a new song. Throughout the Psalms, a "new song" is sung when God does something new. For the returned community, it means the new thing God has done in bringing them back, rebuilding, and keeping them safe. Praise includes dancing and music with tambourine and lyre.

Verse 4 is wonderful: "The LORD takes pleasure in his people; he adorns the humble with salvation." God is not only worshiped but delights in the worshipers. The humble, those who do not rely on themselves, are crowned with salvation.

Then the psalm takes a surprising turn: "two-edged swords in their hands, to execute vengeance on the nations." This has been read in many ways. In its Old Testament setting, it refers to God's people participating in his justice. The people of God are not passive. In the New Testament, the sword of the Spirit is the word of God (Ephesians 6:17; Hebrews 4:12). The final victory belongs to the Lord, and his people stand with him.

Psalm 150 is the climax. It answers four questions. Where? In his sanctuary and in the mighty heavens, which is everywhere. Why? For his mighty deeds and his excellent greatness. How? With trumpet, harp, lyre, tambourine, strings, pipe, and loud clashing cymbals. Praise is wholehearted and full of sound. Who? "Let everything that has breath praise the LORD." That includes you.

The five books of the Psalter each end with a doxology, and the fifth book ends with this final one that is itself the doxology of the whole. After 150 psalms of laments, confessions, complaints, and hope, the book ends in praise. It tells us where all prayer is meant to end.

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 6:17 identifies the sword of the Spirit as the word of God. Hebrews 4:12: "The word of God is living and active, sharper than any two-edged sword." Revelation 5:9 speaks of the new song sung to the Lamb. Colossians 3:16 says to sing psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs with thankfulness. Luke 19:40: if the people were silent, the stones would cry out. Revelation 19:1-6 is the hallelujah of the multitude.

STEP 6

Application

Use Psalm 150 as a morning prayer for a week. Praise with your breath, your voice, and your body.

Sing or listen to a hymn or song that is new to you.

Ask: where is God doing something new that deserves a new song?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Sing or speak a new song to God, and let it be yours.
- Thank him that he takes pleasure in his people.
- Let everything that has breath praise him, and add your own.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 74

"And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?"

ESTHER 4:14

DAY 518 · WEEK 74

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Esther 4:14 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?"

ESTHER 4:14

REST

Meditation

This question was asked by an older cousin to a frightened young queen. It is a question, not a command, and that is part of its power.

"Who knows." Mordecai does not claim certainty. He cannot see the future. He is asking Esther to consider a possibility. God's purposes are often hidden, and we act without a guarantee. Faith lives in the space between what we know and what we hope.

"Whether you have not come to the kingdom." Esther did not choose to be queen. She was taken to the palace by force, hidden her identity, and lived in a gilded cage. Everything that happened to her could have looked like loss. Mordecai invites her to see a different story. Her position was not an accident.

“For such a time as this.” This is a call to the present. Esther was not asked to be queen in some other age. She was asked to act now. Our callings are tied to particular moments: this family, this job, this friendship, this crisis. We do not choose the time, but we are asked to meet it.

The verse comes just after a sobering warning. If she keeps silent, deliverance will come from another place. God does not need us. But he invites us. The honor is in being used.

Keep this verse near when you face a decision that is uncomfortable. You are where you are for a reason. Ask God what he wants to do through you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished Nehemiah and read the book of Esther. You saw the wall dedicated with two choirs and a sound of joy heard far away, and you saw how quickly the people slipped back into their old ways. Nehemiah ended with a prayer: “Remember me, O my God, for good.” Then you moved to Persia and read the story of Esther, in which God’s name never appears and his hand is everywhere. You watched a queen risk her life, a sleepless king, a proud man hanged on his own gallows, and a day of sorrow turned into gladness. In Psalm 145, you praised the God who is near to all who call on him. In Psalms 149 and 150, you sang a new song and let everything that has breath praise the LORD.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Esther was asked to risk her position for others. What position, gift, or influence has God given you that could be used for someone else?

The book of Esther never names God, yet his work is visible. Where do you see his hidden hand in your own story?

Both Nehemiah and Esther point to a people who still need a better deliverer. How does Jesus fulfill what these books long for?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to give you courage and wisdom for the season you are in.

Thank him for his hidden hand and nearness.

Rest in him.

DAY 519 · WEEK 75

Psalm 115

Not to us, O LORD, not to us, but to your name give glory

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 115. This psalm contrasts the living God with lifeless idols. Read it as the song of a small, exposed community in a land full of other gods.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 115 was probably used in the second temple period. It begins with a famous line: "Not to us, O LORD." The nations ask, "Where is their God?" That question could be asked of the returned exiles, a small people under Persian rule. The psalm's answer is that God is in heaven and does as he pleases, while the gods of the nations are silver and gold, made by human hands.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Not to us, O LORD, not to us, but to your name give glory, for the sake of your steadfast love and your faithfulness!" (v. 1).
2. "Why should the nations say, Where is their God?" (v. 2).
3. "Our God is in the heavens; he does all that he pleases" (v. 3).
4. "Their idols are silver and gold, the work of human hands" (v. 4).
5. "They have mouths, but do not speak; eyes, but do not see" (v. 5).
6. "Those who make them become like them; so do all who trust in them" (v. 8).
7. "O Israel, trust in the LORD! He is their help and their shield" (v. 9).
8. "The heavens are the LORD's heavens, but the earth he has given to the children of man" (v. 16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a humble prayer. “Not to us.” The people had just been through exile, return, and rebuilding, and they could easily have taken pride in their achievements. They deflect the glory. It belongs to God’s name, for the sake of his steadfast love and faithfulness.

The taunt of the nations is real: “Where is their God?” Israel has no king, no army, no visible image of their God. The answer is bold. Our God is in heaven and does whatever he pleases. He is not an object to be carried around. He is free and sovereign.

Then comes a sharp description of idols. They have mouths but cannot speak, eyes but cannot see, ears but cannot hear, noses but cannot smell, hands that cannot feel, feet that cannot walk. They are lifeless things dressed as persons. And the verdict in verse 8 is chilling: “Those who make them become like them.” What we worship shapes us. Whoever puts trust in something dead becomes deadened. Whoever worships power becomes hard; whoever worships money becomes cold. We become what we love.

The next section calls three groups to trust: Israel, the house of Aaron, and those who fear the LORD. Three times: “He is their help and their shield.” The refrain is a reminder that trust is a communal act.

The psalm closes with a blessing. “May the LORD give you increase, you and your children.” And with a promise of praise: “The dead do not praise the LORD… But we will bless the LORD from this time forth and forevermore.” Life is for praise.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 44:9-20 is a satirical description of idol-making. Romans 1:21-23 says people exchanged the glory of the immortal God for images. 1 John 5:21: “Little children, keep yourselves from idols.” 2 Corinthians 3:18: we are being transformed into the image of the Lord from one degree of glory to another. Colossians 3:5 says that covetousness is idolatry. John 8:50 shows Jesus seeking not his own glory.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you might be becoming like. What do you give your attention and trust to most?

When you succeed at something, pray “Not to us, O LORD” before accepting the praise.

Identify one modern idol (money, image, comfort, control) and renounce it in prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give God the glory for something you were tempted to take credit for.

Confess any trust in idols.

Ask him to bless those who trust him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 75

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

DAY 520 · WEEK 75

Psalm 71

In you, O LORD, do I take refuge, the prayer of the aging saint

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 71. This is the prayer of an old believer, looking back on a lifetime of God's faithfulness and forward to the end. Read it slowly, as if praying it for a grandparent, or for yourself in forty years.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 71 has no title, but it follows Psalm 70 and reads like a continuation. The writer has trusted God from youth and now faces old age and enemies. Many in the second temple community, old men who had seen the first temple, would have prayed it. It is the great psalm of lifelong faith.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In you, O LORD, do I take refuge; let me never be put to shame!" (v. 1).
2. "Be to me a rock of refuge, to which I may continually come" (v. 3).
3. "For you, O Lord, are my hope, my trust, O LORD, from my youth" (v. 5).
4. "Do not cast me off in the time of old age; forsake me not when my strength is spent" (v. 9).
5. "But I will hope continually and will praise you yet more and more" (v. 14).
6. "O God, from my youth you have taught me, and I still proclaim your wondrous deeds" (v. 17).
7. "So even to old age and gray hairs, O God, do not forsake me, until I proclaim your might to another generation" (v. 18).

8 “You who have made me see many troubles and calamities will revive me again; from the depths of the earth you will bring me up again” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is an elder’s prayer. The speaker has relied on God since birth: “Upon you I have leaned from before my birth; you are he who took me from my mother’s womb.” God has been faithful through every season. Yet old age brings new fears: “Do not cast me off in the time of old age.” Strength is ebbing, and enemies see weakness as an opportunity: “God has forsaken him; pursue and seize him.”

The psalmist’s answer is not despair but renewed praise. “I will hope continually and will praise you yet more and more.” Hope grows rather than fades. His mouth will tell of God’s righteous acts all day long, “for their number is past my knowledge.” He cannot count them all.

The center of the psalm is verse 18. The old man asks for continued life with a purpose: “until I proclaim your might to another generation, your power to all those to come.” This is what old age is for. The aim of long life is not comfort but testimony. Those who have walked with God for decades are a treasure to the church. They have seen troubles and calamities, and they can say, “God brought me through.”

The psalm ends with confidence: “You will revive me again.” The one who made him see many troubles will bring him up from the depths. There is a note here that reaches beyond this life, toward resurrection. And the final word is praise, with harp, lyre, and lips that shout for joy.

For the young, the psalm is a challenge: build a life of trust now, so that you can pray this in old age. For the old, it is a comfort.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 46:4: “Even to your old age I am he, and to gray hairs I will carry you.” Titus 2:2-5 charges older believers to teach the younger. 2 Corinthians 4:16: “Though our outer self is wasting away, our inner self is being renewed day by day.” Psalm 92:14: the righteous “still bear fruit in old age.” 2 Timothy 4:7-8: “I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race.” Deuteronomy 6:7: teach your children.

STEP 6

Application

Call or visit an older believer and ask them to tell you how God has been faithful to them.

If you are older, write down three stories of God's faithfulness to pass on.

Pray verse 18 for yourself: "Let me proclaim your might to another generation."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for being your hope from youth.

Ask him not to cast you away when you are old or weak.

Pray for the generation that comes after you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 75

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

DAY 521 · WEEK 75

Psalm 144

Blessed be the LORD, my rock, a new song for restoration

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 15 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 144. This is a psalm of David asking for deliverance from enemies, and it ends with a vision of a blessed people. Read the first half as a war prayer and the second half as a prayer for peace.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 144 is attributed to David and combines several earlier psalms. It begins with praise to God as the trainer of his hands for battle and ends with a vision of a prosperous society. It sits well here in the unit because the returned exiles lived under constant threat. They longed for the kind of safety and blessing that the final verses describe.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Blessed be the LORD, my rock, who trains my hands for war, and my fingers for battle” (v. 1).
2. “He is my steadfast love and my fortress, my stronghold and my deliverer, my shield and he in whom I take refuge” (v. 2).
3. “O LORD, what is man that you regard him, or the son of man that you think of him?” (v. 3).
4. “Man is like a breath; his days are like a passing shadow” (v. 4).
5. “I will sing a new song to you, O God” (v. 9).
6. “Rescue me and deliver me from the hand of foreigners, whose mouths speak lies” (v. 11).
7. “May our sons in their youth be like plants full grown” (v. 12).

8 “Blessed are the people to whom such blessings fall! Blessed are the people whose God is the LORD!” (v. 15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a remarkable confession. David is a warrior, and he knows his skill is a gift: God “trains my hands for war.” Strength and courage come from God. He lists eight names for him: rock, steadfast love, fortress, stronghold, deliverer, shield, refuge, and the one who subdues peoples. Each is a different image of security.

Then comes a note of wonder: “O LORD, what is man that you regard him?” It is a smaller echo of Psalm 8. Man is a breath, a shadow. And yet God notices. The contrast between our frailty and God’s attention is the basis for the plea that follows: “Bow your heavens, O LORD, and come down.” The psalmist asks for the kind of divine intervention seen at Sinai, with mountains smoking and lightning flashing.

The second half moves from threat to peace. The prayer is for sons like full-grown plants, daughters like carved pillars, barns full, flocks multiplying, no breach in the walls and no cry in the streets. This is a picture of shalom: safe homes, thriving families, plentiful provision. It is what the returned exiles hoped for, with a rebuilt wall and a re-established covenant community.

The last line is profound: “Blessed are the people whose God is the LORD!” The blessing is not just the peace and plenty. It is having the LORD as God. If the barns are empty and the sons are weak, the people are still blessed because they have him. If everything else were provided and he were missing, they would have nothing.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 8:4 is the source of the question about man. Hebrews 2:6-9 applies it to Jesus, who tasted death for everyone. James 4:14: “You are a mist that appears for a little time and then vanishes.” Ephesians 6:10-17 describes spiritual warfare and armor. Matthew 5:3-12 gives the blessings of the kingdom. Revelation 21:3: “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man.”

STEP 6

Application

Name eight ways God is your security, as David did in verse 2.

Pray for peace and flourishing for the families of your church and neighborhood.

Ask yourself whether you count yourself blessed because of what God gives, or because he is your God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as your rock, fortress, and refuge.
- Ask him to teach your hands and bless your people.
- Tell him you want to sing a new song.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 75

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

DAY 522 · WEEK 75

1 Chronicles 1:1-2:55

Genealogies from Adam through Judah's line [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 109 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 1:1-2:55. This is a survey reading, so do not try to study every name. Read it as the opening of a story: the line from Adam to Abraham to Israel to Judah. Watch where the genealogy slows down.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chronicles was written for the returned community, probably after 400 BC, to answer a pressing question: are we still the people of God? The first book begins with nine chapters of genealogies, a surprising start. But to a people who had lost their kingdom, temple, and land, these lists said: you belong. The line from Adam never broke. Chronicles retells the history of Israel from Adam to the decree of Cyrus, focusing on David, the temple, and the hope of restoration. It is a different perspective from Samuel and Kings, which were written in exile.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Adam, Seth, Enosh" (1:1).
2. "The sons of Noah: Shem, Ham, and Japheth" (1:4).
3. "Abraham, that is, Abraham" (1:27).
4. "The sons of Abraham: Isaac and Ishmael" (1:28).
5. "These are the sons of Israel: Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, Zebulun" (2:1).
6. "The sons of Judah: Er, Onan, and Shelah" (2:3).
7. "Achan, the troubler of Israel, who broke faith in the matter of the devoted thing" (2:7).
8. "Jesse fathered Eliab his firstborn… David the seventh" (2:13-15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The genealogy begins with Adam and moves quickly through the nations of the world. The Chronicler wants his readers to see that Israel's story is part of the world's story. All nations descend from Adam and Noah, and Israel is chosen out of them. Then the lists narrow: Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and the twelve sons.

Then the writer slows down on Judah, listing his sons and their descendants. Judah is the line of the king, and the lists lead toward David. The genealogy is not neutral. It is shaped to tell a story of promise. Even in the lists, we see grace: Tamar, who was wronged and acted, is named. Rahab, once a Canaanite prostitute, is in the line of Judah. Even Achan, the troubler, is remembered, a reminder that failure is part of the story.

Why include these names? In the ancient world, a genealogy was a kind of identity card. To the returned exiles, the names proved that they were not forgotten. Every name stands for a person known to God. The Chronicler's point is that the promises to Abraham and David were still alive.

There is also a subtle emphasis on God's choice. David is the seventh son of Jesse, the youngest, not the oldest. The one who was passed over by his own family is the one God chose. Throughout the Chronicles, the surprising pattern appears again and again: God chooses the unexpected.

As you read, do not feel lost in the names. Treat them like a family photo album. You do not need to know everyone in it, but you can feel that you belong to a story much bigger than yourself.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 1:1-17 opens the New Testament with a genealogy of Jesus, including Tamar, Rahab, and Ruth. Luke 3:23-38 traces Jesus back to Adam. Luke 10:20 says to rejoice that your names are written in heaven. Philippians 4:3 speaks of names in the book of life. Revelation 21:27 mentions the Lamb's book of life. Acts 17:26 says that God made from one man every nation.

STEP 6

Application

Take a few minutes to write the names of three generations of your family. Thank God for each.

Remember that you are known by name. Read Luke 10:20 aloud.

Notice God's surprising choices, in Scripture and in your life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that your name is known to him.

Thank him that no one is forgotten in his plan.

Ask him to keep you faithful to your place.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 75

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

DAY 523 · WEEK 75

1 Chronicles 3:1-5:26

David's descendants; Levi, Reuben, Gad, half-Manasseh [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 3:1-5:26. This is another survey reading. Look for the royal line of David, the prayer of Jabez, and the notes about warriors who cried out to God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The next section lists David's sons, the kings of Judah to the exile, and then the genealogies of the remaining tribes. Chapter 3 ends with the line of David continuing after the exile through Jehoiachin and Zerubbabel. The Chronicler is saying that the Davidic line did not die in Babylon. Scattered through the lists are brief stories, little windows into lives.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "These were the sons of David who were born to him in Hebron" (3:1).
2. "The sons of Jeconiah, the captive: Shealtiel his son… Zerubbabel" (3:17-19).
3. "Jabez was more honorable than his brothers; and his mother called his name Jabez, saying, Because I bore him in pain" (4:9).
4. "Jabez called upon the God of Israel, saying, Oh that you would bless me and enlarge my border" (4:10).
5. "And God granted what he asked" (4:10).
6. "For they cried out to God in the battle, and he granted their urgent plea because they trusted in him" (5:20).
7. "But they broke faith with the God of their fathers, and whored after the gods of the peoples of the land" (5:25).
8. "So the God of Israel stirred up the spirit of Pul king of Assyria" (5:26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The royal line is carefully traced. David's sons are listed, including Solomon, and then the long line of the kings of Judah. After the exile, the line continues: Jehoiachin, Shealtiel, and Zerubbabel, who led the first return. This is deliberate. Chronicles says that the house of David did not end. God's covenant with David stands, even though there is no king on the throne at the time of writing.

In the middle of the genealogies, we find a short story of a man named Jabez. His name means "pain," because his mother bore him in sorrow. He could have lived under the weight of that name. Instead, he cried out to God. He asked for blessing, for enlarged borders, for God's hand to be with him, and to be kept from harm. "And God granted what he asked." The story tells us that our origins do not determine our future. A person with a painful beginning can pray boldly and be heard. But note the point is not a formula for prosperity. It is trust in God's ability to bless.

Chapter 5 includes another telling detail about the tribes east of the Jordan, who "cried out to God in the battle, and he granted their urgent plea because they trusted in him." Victory is credited to trust, not strength. But by the end of the chapter, those same tribes broke faith and were exiled. This is the Chronicler's pattern: faith leads to blessing, and unfaithfulness leads to loss, but prayer is always open.

Notice also the ending: "The God of Israel stirred up the spirit of Pul king of Assyria." Even the exile is seen as God's hand at work. The same phrase, "stirred up the spirit," appeared in Ezra 1:1 for Cyrus. God stirs up both judgment and restoration.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 1:12-13 includes Zerubbabel in the line of Jesus. Luke 11:9-10 says to ask, seek, and knock. James 4:2: "You do not have, because you do not ask." Ephesians 3:20 says God is able to do far more than all we ask or think. Psalm 34:6: "This poor man cried, and the LORD heard him." John 16:24: "Ask, and you will receive, that your joy may be full."

STEP 6

Application

If you carry a painful name or beginning, offer it to God, and ask him to rename your future.

Pray a bold, specific prayer today, in line with God's character and purposes.

When facing a battle, practice crying out to God first.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Cry to God about where your beginnings were painful.

Ask him to bless you and enlarge your borders for his purpose.

Thank him for hearing those who cry out.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 75

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

DAY 524 · WEEK 75

1 Chronicles 6:1-9:44

Levitical genealogies; Jerusalem after the exile [survey]

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 124 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 6:1-9:44. This is the last survey reading from the genealogies. Pay attention to the Levites, who serve in worship, and to the people who returned to Jerusalem at the end of chapter 9.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Chronicler gives special attention to the tribe of Levi, because the temple and its worship were central for the returned community. Chapter 6 lists the priestly line from Aaron and the singers appointed by David. Chapter 9 ends the genealogies with a roll call of those who returned from exile and lived in Jerusalem. The introduction is over, and the story of David begins in chapter 10.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “These are the men whom David put in charge of the service of song in the house of the LORD” (6:31).
2. “And they ministered with song before the tabernacle of the tent of meeting” (6:32).
3. “But Aaron and his sons made offerings on the altar of burnt offering” (6:49).
4. “All these, chosen as gatekeepers at the thresholds, were 212” (9:22).
5. “Now the first to dwell again in their possessions in their cities were Israel, the priests, the Levites, and the temple servants” (9:2).
6. “And some of the sons of Judah, Benjamin, Ephraim, and Manasseh lived in Jerusalem” (9:3).
7. “Some of them had charge of the vessels of service” (9:28).

(8) “They were in the singers, the heads of fathers” houses of the Levites, dwelling in the chambers of the temple, free from other service, for they were on duty day and night’ (9:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Levites are given a large place for a reason. The Chronicler wanted the community to remember that worship is not an afterthought. After the exile, with no king, the temple and its worship were the center of national life. Levi’s line is listed in detail: the gatekeepers, the singers, and the priests. Even the musicians are named. David appointed men to the service of song, and they “ministered with song” before the tabernacle until Solomon built the temple.

This is one of the Chronicler’s emphases. Music is ministry. Those who sang were serving in the house of the LORD, just as those who offered sacrifices. The worship of God deserves skill, order, and care. Chapter 9 says some singers were “on duty day and night.” There was constant praise.

Chapter 9 ends with the list of those who settled in Jerusalem after the exile. It mirrors the lists in Nehemiah 11. After the long genealogy, we arrive at the present: the people are back, the city is occupied, the work of worship resumes. The genealogy is not an empty record. It leads to the community that is reading it.

Then the chapter ends with a reminder of King Saul’s genealogy, and immediately chapter 10 will tell of his death. The mood shifts. The introduction is over. The Chronicler has given us a map of the people. Now he will tell the story.

Do not be discouraged if these chapters feel dry. They are the foundation. Everything that follows, the story of David’s kingdom and the temple, rests on the belief that God knows his people by name and has a place for each.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Peter 2:9 calls the church a royal priesthood. Hebrews 4:14-16 names Jesus as our great high priest. Revelation 1:6 says he made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father. Ephesians 5:19 says to sing and make melody to the Lord with your heart. Colossians 3:16 mentions teaching one another with psalms and hymns. Romans 12:1 invites us to present our bodies as a living sacrifice.

STEP 6

Application

Think about those who serve behind the scenes in your church, such as musicians, ushers, and volunteers. Thank one of them.

If you have a musical or creative gift, ask how God might use it in worship.

Practice offering your ordinary work as service to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he has a place for each person in his work.

Thank someone who serves behind the scenes.

Ask him to show you your place.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 75

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

DAY 525 · WEEK 75

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Chronicles 16:34 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"

1 CHRONICLES 16:34

REST

Meditation

This verse comes from the song David gave to Asaph and his brothers on the day the ark was brought to Jerusalem. You will read the whole song in a few days, in 1 Chronicles 16. It is a verse that bridges the Chronicler's world and yours.

"Oh give thanks to the LORD." This is a command in the form of an invitation. The word for thanks means to acknowledge, to confess, to give credit where it is due. Thanks is not just a feeling but a public statement. We say out loud who God is and what he has done.

"For he is good." The reason for thanks is God's character. He is good in himself. Not just good to us when things go well, but good in his nature. Jesus said, "No one is good except God alone" (Mark 10:18). All goodness comes from him.

“For his steadfast love endures forever.” The Hebrew word is hesed, covenant love, loyal love. It is the love that sticks. The word “endures” says that it does not run out. After the exile, the returned community needed this assurance. They had seen the covenant curses fall. And yet his love was still there.

The verse recurs again and again in the Bible: in Ezra 3:11, in Psalm 136, and in Jeremiah 33:11. When something appears so many times in Scripture, God is telling us to remember it. It was the song of the people at every major moment: bringing the ark, dedicating the temple, laying the foundation. It can be your song too, at every turning point in your life.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the book of Chronicles with the great genealogies. You moved from Adam through Noah, Abraham, Israel, and Judah, and saw the royal line of David continue past the exile to Zerubbabel. You met Jabez, whose painful name did not decide his future, and the eastern tribes who cried out in battle and were heard. You read about the Levites, singers, and gatekeepers who served in worship, and you saw the list end with those who returned to Jerusalem. Along the way, you prayed three psalms: Psalm 115, against idols and for God’s glory alone; Psalm 71, the prayer of the aged believer; and Psalm 144, a prayer for deliverance and for a blessed people.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Chronicler’s lists told the exiles that they belonged. Where do you find assurance that you belong to God’s people?

Jabez prayed boldly for blessing. What bold prayer, consistent with God’s will, might you offer this week?

Jesus appears in a genealogy that includes sinners and outsiders. How does that shape the way you see your own family story?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is good and his steadfast love endures forever.

Thank him for your place in his story.

Rest in him.

DAY 526 · WEEK 76

1 Chronicles 10:1-13:14

Saul's death; David made king; the ark journey

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 77 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 10:1-13:14. Chronicles passes over Saul's life and tells only his death, then moves quickly to David's anointing as king over all Israel. Read for what the Chronicler chooses to emphasize.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Chronicler's story begins with the death of Saul, which he gives a theological explanation: Saul died for his unfaithfulness. Then, in a single move, "all Israel" gathers at Hebron to make David king. The Chronicler skips David's years as a fugitive and his seven-year reign over Judah. He wants to show a unified nation under God's chosen king, with David's first act being to capture Jerusalem and bring the ark there.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "So Saul died for his breach of faith. He broke faith with the LORD in that he did not keep the command of the LORD" (10:13).
2. "And he did not seek guidance from the LORD. Therefore the LORD put him to death" (10:14).
3. "Then all Israel gathered to David at Hebron and said, Behold, we are your bone and flesh" (11:1).
4. "And the LORD your God said to you, You shall be shepherd of my people Israel" (11:2).
5. "And David became greater and greater, for the LORD of hosts was with him" (11:9).
6. "These were the chiefs of David's mighty men, who gave him strong support in his kingdom" (11:10).

7. “And David said to all the assembly of Israel, If it seems good to you, and from the LORD our God… let us bring again the ark of our God to us” (13:2-3).

8. “And Uzzah put out his hand to take hold of the ark… and God struck him down because he put out his hand to the ark” (13:9-10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Chronicler’s judgment on Saul is one sentence: he broke faith and he did not seek the LORD. That is the key. The central question of Chronicles is whether the kings “sought the LORD.” This phrase recurs throughout the books and is the test of every reign. Saul did not. David did.

The story shifts to David at Hebron, where all the tribes come together. Notice the key phrase: the LORD said, “You shall be shepherd of my people.” David’s reign is a gift from God. Jerusalem is taken, and the Chronicler stresses that David’s power grew because “the LORD of hosts was with him.” The list of mighty men follows, each of whom contributed to the kingdom. Chapter 12 describes the soldiers who came from all the tribes: “all of one mind to make David king.” Unity around God’s king is a major theme.

Then David consults with the leaders about the ark, which had been neglected since the days of Eli. “Let us bring again the ark of our God to us, for we did not seek it in the days of Saul.” The ark was the symbol of God’s presence, and bringing it to Jerusalem would make the city the spiritual center.

But the first attempt fails. They put the ark on a new cart, as the Philistines had done, rather than carry it on the shoulders of Levites as the law prescribed. When the oxen stumble, Uzzah reaches out to steady the ark and dies on the spot. It is a shocking moment. David is angry and afraid. The lesson is that good intentions are not enough. God’s presence is holy, and it must be approached on his terms. The ark is left at the house of Obed-edom for three months, and that house is blessed.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 12:28-29 says our God is a consuming fire, and we should offer acceptable worship with reverence and awe. John 4:24 says true worshipers worship in spirit and truth. Matthew 2:6 quotes Micah on the shepherd of Israel, and John 10:11 says Jesus is the good shepherd. Ephesians 4:3-6 urges unity of the Spirit. Leviticus 10:1-3 and Numbers 4:15 show the holiness of sacred things. 1 Samuel 13:13-14 records Saul’s disobedience.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself how you seek the LORD in your decisions, not after the fact but before.

Think about approaching God with reverence. Is there any casualness in your worship that needs correcting?

Pray for unity among believers around Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to make you one who seeks him, as David did.
- Confess where you have gone your own way.
- Ask for his presence.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 76

"Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever."

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

DAY 527 · WEEK 76

1 Chronicles 14:1-17:27

David's victories; the ark in Jerusalem; the covenant

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 14:1-17:27. The ark comes to Jerusalem with joy, David sings a great psalm of thanksgiving, and God makes his covenant with David. Read chapter 16 as worship and chapter 17 as promise.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the failure of the first attempt, David prepares a tent for the ark and has the Levites carry it properly. The procession is a feast of music and dancing. David then appoints Asaph and his brothers to give thanks daily before the ark. Then David, living in a house of cedar, wants to build a house for God, and God responds with a covenant that is the pivot of the whole Bible: God will build David a house.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For none but the Levites may carry the ark of God" (15:2).
2. "Thus all Israel brought up the ark of the covenant of the LORD with shouting, to the sound of the horn, trumpets, and cymbals, and made loud music on harps and lyres" (15:28).
3. "On that day David first appointed that thanksgiving be sung to the LORD by Asaph and his brothers" (16:7).
4. "Oh give thanks to the LORD; call upon his name; make known his deeds among the peoples!" (16:8).
5. "Sing to the LORD, all the earth! Tell of his salvation from day to day" (16:23).
6. "Moreover, I declare to you that the LORD will build you a house" (17:10).

7. “I will raise up your offspring after you… and I will establish his kingdom” (17:11).
8. “I will establish his throne forever” (17:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This time David does it right. The Levites carry the ark on their shoulders, as the law prescribed. The music and sacrifices are offered. David even dances in joy, which his wife Michal despises, though the Chronicler does not dwell on it. The ark is placed in the tent David prepared, and then David delivers a psalm that is a compilation of what we know as parts of Psalms 105, 96, and 106. It is a missionary hymn: “Make known his deeds among the peoples! Sing to the LORD, all the earth! Declare his glory among the nations.” David was not satisfied with a local, tribal religion. His praise reached to all peoples.

The psalm ends with the refrain that you memorized at the weekly rest: “Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever.” Then comes the daily ministry of the Levites. The worship of Israel was constant.

Then comes chapter 17, the greatest moment. David says, “I dwell in a house of cedar, but the ark of the covenant of the LORD is under a tent.” He wants to build a house for God. God, through Nathan, turns it around: you will not build a house for me, but I will build a house for you. A dynasty. “I will raise up your offspring after you, one of your own sons, and I will establish his kingdom. He shall build a house for me, and I will establish his throne forever.” Solomon will build the temple, but the promise reaches farther. The Chronicler, writing after the monarchy ended, holds on to this promise. The throne of David will be established forever, and that can only be fulfilled in someone greater than any of David’s sons.

David’s response is a model prayer: “Who am I, O LORD God, and what is my house, that you have brought me thus far?” It is humility before grace.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 1:32-33: the angel says that the Lord God will give Jesus the throne of his father David, and “of his kingdom there will be no end.” Hebrews 1:5 quotes “I will be to him a father” from this chapter. Acts 13:22-23 connects David and Jesus. Matthew 28:19 sends the church to all nations. Romans 15:9-11 shows the nations praising God. Psalm 89:3-4 recalls the covenant with David.

STEP 6

Application

Make the praise of 16:8-36 your own. Read it aloud and mention God’s deeds in your life.

Ask: who might I tell about God's deeds this week? Make known his deeds among the peoples.

Pray David's prayer: "Who am I, O LORD God, that you have brought me thus far?"

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God and call upon his name.
- Ask him to help you make known his deeds among the nations.
- Thank him for the covenant he made with David.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 76

"Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever."

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

DAY 528 · WEEK 76

Psalm 96

Sing to the LORD a new song, David's psalm at the ark

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 96. You read this in Unit 3 as a song of the nations. Notice that much of it is quoted in 1 Chronicles 16, where David first gave it to Asaph, and read it now as the missionary song of the returned people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 96 appears almost word for word in 1 Chronicles 16:23-33. The Chronicler included it because it captures the heart of David's worship: a song that sends praise to the whole earth. A small, fragile community, rebuilding in a corner of the Persian empire, still sang that God is king over all nations. That is the faith of the returned exiles. They did not shrink their God to fit their circumstances.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh sing to the LORD a new song; sing to the LORD, all the earth!" (v. 1).
2. "Sing to the LORD, bless his name; tell of his salvation from day to day" (v. 2).
3. "Declare his glory among the nations, his marvelous works among all the peoples!" (v. 3).
4. "For great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised; he is to be feared above all gods" (v. 4).
5. "For all the gods of the peoples are worthless idols, but the LORD made the heavens" (v. 5).
6. "Ascribe to the LORD, O families of the peoples, ascribe to the LORD glory and strength" (v. 7).
7. "Say among the nations, The LORD reigns!" (v. 10).

8 “He will judge the world in righteousness, and the peoples in his faithfulness” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a missionary hymn. Its first three verses are a chain of commands: sing, bless, tell, declare. The song is not meant to stay in the temple. The goal is to tell the nations. This was an extraordinary thing for a small people to say. They had nothing to boast about: no army, no king, no wall until recently. And yet they said, “Declare his glory among the nations.”

The reason is who God is. He is great and above all gods. The gods of the peoples are “worthless idols,” a word that plays on “elilim,” meaning “nothings.” But the LORD made the heavens. The contrast is between nothing and the Maker. Having heard Psalm 115 only a few days ago, you recognize the theme.

Then the psalm calls the “families of the peoples” to ascribe glory to the LORD and to bring an offering and come into his courts. The nations are not simply an audience; they are invited to worship. This is the vision first given to Abraham: “In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed.”

The announcement at the center is the best news: “Say among the nations, The LORD reigns!” The heavens rejoice, the earth is glad, the sea roars, the fields exult, and the trees of the forest sing for joy. All creation celebrates because he is coming to judge. The judgment is good news: it means that wrongs will be set right, the oppressed will be vindicated, and the world will finally be put in order. He will judge “in righteousness” and “in his faithfulness.”

You read this in Unit 3 as an invitation. Today, remember that the people who sang it were few and weak. And God used them.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 12:3 promises that all families of the earth will be blessed through Abraham. Matthew 28:19-20 sends the disciples to make disciples of all nations. Acts 17:30-31 says God will judge the world in righteousness by a man he has appointed. Revelation 7:9-10 shows people from every nation praising God. Romans 10:14-15 asks how people will hear without a preacher. Revelation 11:15: “The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ.”

STEP 6

Application

Tell someone this week one thing about God that you believe is good news for them.

Pray for a missionary or a people group that has not heard.

Sing or read the psalm aloud outdoors, joining the trees of the forest.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Sing to the LORD a new song, in your own words.

Tell him he is greater than every other thing you are tempted to rely on.

Ask him to help you declare his glory.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 76

"Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever."

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

DAY 529 · WEEK 76

Psalm 105:1-15

Give thanks to the LORD; remember his covenant

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 15 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 105:1-15. You read this in earlier units as a recital of God's covenant faithfulness. The first fifteen verses were also part of David's song in 1 Chronicles 16. Notice how the song uses the covenant with Abraham as a ground for present thanks.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 105 is a long historical psalm, recounting God's care of Israel from Abraham to the conquest. The first fifteen verses were sung on the day the ark came to Jerusalem (1 Chronicles 16:8-22). They set out the call to remember and then the heart of what they were to remember: the covenant. The returned exiles were reading this in a time when the land was again precarious. It reminded them that the promise to Abraham did not depend on their strength.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh give thanks to the LORD; call upon his name; make known his deeds among the peoples!" (v. 1).
2. "Sing to him, sing praises to him; tell of all his wondrous works!" (v. 2).
3. "Let the hearts of those who seek the LORD rejoice!" (v. 3).
4. "Seek the LORD and his strength; seek his presence continually!" (v. 4).
5. "Remember the wondrous works that he has done, his miracles, and the judgments he uttered" (v. 5).
6. "He is the LORD our God; his judgments are in all the earth" (v. 7).

7. “He remembers his covenant forever, the word that he commanded, for a thousand generations” (v. 8).

8. “When they were few in number, of little account, and sojourners in it” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a string of imperatives, nine in a row: give thanks, call, make known, sing, sing praises, tell, glory, rejoice, seek. Worship in Scripture is active, public, and full of verbs. Notice verse 3: “Let the hearts of those who seek the LORD rejoice.” Seeking, which is often hard, is joyful.

Verse 5 gives the central command: remember. “Remember the wondrous works that he has done.” The main work of faith is memory. We forget so easily. The returned exiles had been through trauma, and remembering God’s past acts was how they kept hope alive. For you too, remembering is a spiritual discipline. Keep a journal, mark anniversaries, tell stories.

The heart of the psalm is verses 8 to 11: God “remembers his covenant forever.” Not just for one or two generations, but “for a thousand generations.” The covenant given to Abraham, repeated to Isaac and Jacob, includes the promise of Canaan. That promise was kept even though Israel was “few in number, of little account, and sojourners.” The people were small, weak, and wandering, yet God protected them: “He allowed no one to oppress them; he rebuked kings on their account.” Pharaoh and Abimelech are the examples. God said of the patriarchs, “Touch not my anointed ones, do my prophets no harm.”

For the post-exilic community, the phrase “few in number, of little account” described them exactly. And the psalm tells them that their smallness did not matter to God. The covenant he made held them. This is a major part of the Chronicler’s message: you are small, but you are the people to whom God made promises, and he will keep them.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 22:19: “Do this in remembrance of me.” Deuteronomy 7:7-9 says God did not set his love on Israel because they were many, but because he loved them and kept his oath. 1 Corinthians 1:26-29 says God chooses the weak and lowly. Galatians 3:29: “If you are Christ’s, then you are Abraham’s offspring.” Luke 1:72-73 says God remembered his holy covenant. Matthew 28:20: “I am with you always.”

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of ten “wondrous works” of God in your life. Read it aloud this week.

Take the Lord's Supper, or think about it if you are not able, and remember Christ's work.

Seek the LORD's presence continually: set a time each day to be still with him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks and remember his wondrous works, naming one.
- Thank him that he remembers his covenant forever.
- Ask him to let you seek his face always.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 76

"Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever."

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

DAY 530 · WEEK 76

1 Chronicles 18:1-22:19

David's victories; the census; preparing for the Temple

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 109 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 18:1-22:19. David's victories are summarized, and the book tells of his census sin and the choice of the temple site. David then prepares for the temple he will not build. Notice what the Chronicler leaves out.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Chronicler summarizes David's wars in a single chapter or two, and he leaves out the story of Bathsheba and Uriah entirely. This is not a cover-up, since the readers knew Samuel and Kings. His purpose is different. He wants to show the faithful side of David and focus on the temple. The one sin he does include is the census, because it led to the site of the temple.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And the LORD gave victory to David wherever he went" (18:6).
2. "Satan stood against Israel and incited David to number Israel" (21:1).
3. "But the king's word prevailed against Joab" (21:4).
4. "And God was displeased with this thing, and he struck Israel" (21:7).
5. "I have sinned greatly in that I have done this thing. But now, please take away the iniquity of your servant, for I have acted very foolishly" (21:8).
6. "Let us fall into the hand of the LORD, for his mercy is very great, but let me not fall into the hand of man" (21:13).
7. "But I will buy it for the full price. I will not take for the LORD what is yours, nor offer a burnt offering that costs me nothing" (21:24).

8 “Here shall be the house of the LORD God and here the altar of burnt offering for Israel” (22:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Chronicler selects. He tells us about David’s victories and his order of mighty men, but not about the affair with Bathsheba. He includes the census, a sin that brought a plague upon Israel and killed 70,000 people. Why this one? Because the story ends with David buying the threshing floor of Ornan the Jebusite, where he sees the angel of the LORD stand with a drawn sword. That place becomes the site of the temple. Out of the worst moment of David’s reign, God brings forth the place where sacrifices will be offered for the sin of the people.

It begins in a surprising way: “Satan stood against Israel and incited David.” The parallel in 2 Samuel 24 says the anger of the LORD incited David. The Chronicler preserves both: God allows the adversary to test, and God’s purposes are served. David’s sin is pride in numbers: he is relying on his army, not on God. When he recognizes his guilt, he confesses honestly. He does not blame Joab, who objected. And when given the choice of punishments, David says, “Let us fall into the hand of the LORD, for his mercy is very great.” Even in judgment, he trusts God’s character more than any human hand.

At the threshing floor, Ornan offers to give the land free. But David says, “I will not offer a burnt offering that costs me nothing.” Real worship costs. David pays full price. And the fire from heaven answers his offering.

Chapter 22 shows David preparing materials for the temple, though God says Solomon, a man of rest, will build it because David has shed much blood. David accepts it. He gathers gold, silver, iron, bronze, and timber “in great quantities” for the son who will build. This is a picture of a person who works for what he will not see finished.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 10:1-14 says the repeated sacrifices could not take away sin, but Christ offered himself once for all. 2 Samuel 24:24 is the parallel verse about costly offerings. Romans 12:1 says to present our bodies as a living sacrifice. 1 Peter 1:18-19 says we were ransomed with the precious blood of Christ. Matthew 6:21: where your treasure is, there your heart will be. Genesis 22:2 mentions Mount Moriah, linked to this site in 2 Chronicles 3:1.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether any of your giving or service “costs you nothing.” What would it look like to give something that costs?

Remember David’s choice: when you fail, fall into the hands of the LORD, for his mercy is great.

Prepare for something you will not see completed, a ministry, a legacy, or a gift for the next generation.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess sin to God honestly and ask him to take away your iniquity.
- Tell him you trust his mercy.
- Thank him for the altar and the sacrifice.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 76

“Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever.”

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

DAY 531 · WEEK 76

1 Chronicles 23:1-26:32

The Levites organized; the courses of priests

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 105 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 23:1-26:32. This is another survey reading. David organizes the Levites, priests, singers, and gatekeepers for the temple. Look for what the lists say about worship and service.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

David, old and full of days, makes Solomon king and then organizes the worship of the future temple. He assigns the Levites to duties, divides the priests into twenty-four divisions, assigns singers by lot, and sets the gatekeepers and treasurers. These chapters may feel technical. The point is that worship in God's house is meant to be ordered, skilled, and shared.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When David was old and full of days, he made Solomon his son king over Israel" (23:1).
2. "For David said, The LORD, the God of Israel, has given rest to his people, and he dwells in Jerusalem forever" (23:25).
3. "And the Levites no longer need to carry the tabernacle" (23:26).
4. "And they are to stand every morning, thanking and praising the LORD, and likewise at evening" (23:30).
5. "David and the chiefs of the service also set apart for the service some of the sons of Asaph, and of Heman, and of Jeduthun, who prophesied with lyres, with harps, and with cymbals" (25:1).

6. “They were all under the direction of their father in the music in the house of the LORD” (25:6).
7. “All these were trained and skillful, 288” (25:7).
8. “And they cast lots for their duties, small and great, teacher and pupil alike” (25:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Levites’ duties change. With the ark at rest in the temple, they no longer need to carry the tabernacle. Instead, they serve in the work of the house: assisting the priests, keeping the courts, cleaning, preparing the showbread, and standing every morning and evening to thank and praise the LORD. Praise was part of their daily work.

The singers receive special attention. Chapter 25 says they “prophesied with lyres, harps, and cymbals.” Music and prophecy are connected. They were trained and skillful, 288 of them, and the lots were cast fairly, “small and great, teacher and pupil alike.” Everyone had a place. Notice the family: “all under the direction of their father.” Their gifts were exercised in families.

In chapter 26, the gatekeepers and treasurers are listed. Those who guarded the doors and kept the treasuries were also Levites. Some were mighty men of valor. The care of the temple’s gifts was a holy trust. Even the doorkeepers had a calling: “I would rather be a doorkeeper in the house of my God” (Psalm 84:10).

Why does the Chronicler give such attention to these matters? Because after the exile, the community needed to rebuild worship on the pattern that God had given. They were to base it not on their own creativity but on what David had commanded “by the word of the LORD.” At the same time, there is freedom: David reorganized the Levites for new circumstances. Order serves worship.

This section teaches that God cares about the practical details of worship and service: who sings, who guards, who keeps the books. Nothing in his house is too small.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Corinthians 14:40 says that all things should be done decently and in order. Romans 12:4-8 describes different gifts in the body. 1 Peter 4:10 says that each has received a gift to serve one another. Ephesians 4:11-12 says Christ gave gifts to equip the saints for the work of ministry. Psalm 84:10 values being a doorkeeper in God’s house. Matthew 25:21: “Well done, good and faithful servant.”

STEP 6

Application

Think of your gift. Ask how it can serve in your local church.

Thank someone who does a quiet or behind-the-scenes task in your community.

Bring order and care to a part of your worship life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the gifts he has given you for his people.

Ask him to show you where to use them.

Ask him to keep you from envying others' gifts.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 76

"Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever."

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

DAY 532 · WEEK 76

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Chronicles 17:27 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever."

1 CHRONICLES 17:27

REST

Meditation

This is the last line of David's prayer after God made the covenant with him. It is a prayer of someone who has just been handed an astonishing promise and is still catching his breath.

"Now you have been pleased to bless." David begins with God's pleasure. God was not forced to bless. He chose to, and he took pleasure in it. The blessing flowed from his good will. It was not earned.

"The house of your servant." David calls himself a servant, though he is the king. His house is not a palace of his own making but a household that God has chosen to bless. Notice that God's promise reached beyond David to his descendants. We are blessed, and so are our children after us.

“That it may continue forever before you.” David asks for the promise to endure. He knows that it will outlast him. The Chronicler wrote these words when there was no king in David’s line on the throne, and so this prayer was an act of hope. The promise had not failed. It was waiting for its fulfillment.

“For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever.” This is the final confidence. The promise rests on the God who made it. David is not bragging about his future. He is resting in God’s word. If God has said it, it will happen.

As a Christian, you can pray this verse with joy. The promise to David is fulfilled in Jesus, and through him we too are blessed forever. When you are tempted to doubt that God will finish what he started, say this verse.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the heart of David’s story according to the Chronicler. You saw how the Chronicler passes quickly over Saul’s death and gathers all Israel to David. You watched the first attempt to move the ark fail with Uzzah, and the second attempt succeed with joyful music. You read David’s psalm of thanksgiving and God’s great covenant promise: “I will establish his throne forever.” You also saw David’s sin in the census and his choice to fall into the hand of the LORD, whose mercy is great, and his refusal to offer a sacrifice that cost him nothing. Then you read about the careful ordering of the Levites, singers, and gatekeepers. In Psalm 96 and the opening of Psalm 105, you sang the songs David gave to Asaph.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

David refused to offer a sacrifice that cost him nothing. What is a cost you are willing to bear for the sake of worship or service?

The promise to David finds its fulfillment in Jesus, the Son of David whose kingdom has no end. How does that give you confidence in God’s promises?

David prepared for a temple that Solomon would build. What are you preparing for the next generation that you may never see completed?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for being pleased to bless his servant.

Thank him for the promise fulfilled in Christ.

Rest in his faithfulness.

DAY 533 · WEEK 77

1 Chronicles 27:1-29:30

Military and civil officers; David's final assembly

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Chronicles 27:1-29:30. David organizes the kingdom, charges Solomon and the people, and gives toward the temple from his own treasure. Then he prays one of the great prayers of the Bible. Read 29:10-20 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the end of 1 Chronicles. David is old, and the transition to Solomon is a formal public event. After listing the officers of the kingdom, the Chronicler records David's final address to the assembly. He gives the plans for the temple to Solomon, urges the leaders to give, and then leads the people in blessing God. Solomon is made king a second time, and David dies "in a good old age, full of days, riches, and honor."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Now therefore in the sight of all Israel, the assembly of the LORD, and in the hearing of our God, observe and seek out all the commandments of the LORD your God" (28:8).
2. "And you, Solomon my son, know the God of your father and serve him with a whole heart and with a willing mind" (28:9).
3. "If you seek him, he will be found by you, but if you forsake him, he will cast you off forever" (28:9).
4. "Be strong and courageous and do it. Do not be afraid and do not be dismayed, for the LORD God, even my God, is with you" (28:20).
5. "Who then is willing to offer willingly, consecrating himself today to the LORD?" (29:5).

6. “Then the people rejoiced because they had given willingly, for with a whole heart they had offered freely to the LORD” (29:9).
7. “Yours, O LORD, is the greatness and the power and the glory and the victory and the majesty” (29:11).
8. “For all things come from you, and of your own have we given you” (29:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David’s charge to Solomon is among the finest pieces of fatherly advice in Scripture. “Know the God of your father and serve him with a whole heart and with a willing mind.” Knowledge comes first, then service. The heart must be whole, undivided, and the mind willing. Then the sober promise: “If you seek him, he will be found by you, but if you forsake him, he will cast you off forever.” This is the Chronicler’s whole theology in one verse. Seek and find; forsake and lose.

David then gives the plans for the temple, which he received “by the Spirit,” and a mass of gold and silver from his own treasure. He challenges the leaders: “Who then is willing to offer willingly?” They respond, and the giving is joyful. The key note is voluntary generosity. “The people rejoiced because they had given willingly.” Giving is meant to be a joy.

Then comes David’s prayer. It begins with praise: “Yours, O LORD, is the greatness and the power and the glory and the victory and the majesty, for all that is in the heavens and in the earth is yours.” It is the source of the line often used in the doxology of the Lord’s Prayer. Then comes the great humility: “Who am I, and what is my people, that we should be able to give thus willingly? For all things come from you, and of your own have we given you.” Nothing we give is ours. We hand back what was lent.

He also prays for the people’s hearts: “Keep this forever in the intentions of the thoughts of the heart of your people, and direct their hearts toward you.” David knows that the heart is the key and that only God can keep it.

The book ends with David’s death and the note that his acts are “written in the chronicles.” The great king is gone, but the work continues.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 6:13 (in some manuscripts) ends the Lord’s Prayer with “For yours is the kingdom and the power and the glory forever.” 2 Corinthians 9:7: “God loves a cheerful giver.” 1 Corinthians 4:7: “What do you have that you did not receive?” Acts 20:35: “It is more blessed

to give than to receive." 2 Timothy 1:5 mentions faith passed down. Proverbs 4:23: guard your heart.

STEP 6

Application

Pray David's prayer about giving: ask God to help you give willingly and joyfully.

Think about who you are charging to "know the God of your father." Pray for them by name.

Write a letter or blessing for a younger person about what you have learned of God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God that everything you have comes from him.
- Offer him something willingly and with joy.
- Ask him to keep your heart loyal to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 77

"If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land."

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

DAY 534 · WEEK 77

2 Chronicles 1:1-4:22

Solomon's wisdom; the Temple built

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 1:1-4:22. Solomon asks for wisdom and begins to build the temple. Read the account of the building as a picture of heaven on earth, and watch for where the Chronicler says the temple was built.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

2 Chronicles begins with Solomon's reign. The Chronicler tells the story with an emphasis on the temple and on Solomon's early faithfulness, leaving out his later failures. Solomon goes to Gibeon to sacrifice, and God appears to him in a dream. Then the building begins on Mount Moriah, the site David purchased.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And Solomon the son of David established himself in his kingdom, and the LORD his God was with him and made him exceedingly great" (1:1).
2. "Give me now wisdom and knowledge to go out and come in before this people" (1:10).
3. "Wisdom and knowledge are granted to you. I will also give you riches, possessions, and honor" (1:12).
4. "Behold, I am about to build a house for the name of the LORD my God" (2:4).
5. "But who is able to build him a house, since heaven, even highest heaven, cannot contain him?" (2:6).
6. "Then Solomon began to build the house of the LORD in Jerusalem on Mount Moriah" (3:1).
7. "And he overlaid the house with gold" (3:7).

8 “And he made the veil of blue and purple and crimson fabrics and fine linen, and he caused cherubim to be embroidered on it” (3:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Solomon’s request for wisdom shows a humble heart. God offers anything, and Solomon asks not for riches or long life but for wisdom to govern God’s people. God grants it and adds the riches he did not ask for. There is a lesson: seek first what matters, and the rest is added.

The Chronicler lingers over the temple. He ties it to the past: it is built on Mount Moriah, “where the LORD had appeared to David his father,” the same site where Abraham offered Isaac in Genesis 22. The significance is that this place, associated with sacrifice and provision, is where God’s presence will dwell.

Solomon’s message to Hiram of Tyre contains a profound statement: “Heaven, even highest heaven, cannot contain him.” The temple is not meant to hold God. It is a place for his name, where he promises to meet his people. Solomon knows the paradox: the infinite God condescends to dwell among humans.

The building is described in lavish detail. Gold overlays the walls. Two great cherubim stand in the Most Holy Place. Two bronze pillars stand at the entrance, named Jachin and Boaz. The bronze altar, the molten sea, the lampstands, and the tables are all made by skilled workmen. The craftsmanship and beauty were part of the worship. God is worthy of the best.

To the returned exiles, the description of the first temple meant something. They had built a smaller one, and the old men wept. But the Chronicler tells them about Solomon’s temple to say, “This is the pattern. This is who God is. His presence once dwelled here, and he will come again.”

STEP 5

Connection

John 2:19-21 says Jesus spoke of the temple of his body. 1 Corinthians 3:16 says “you are God’s temple and God’s Spirit dwells in you.” Ephesians 2:21-22 says the church is a holy temple in the Lord. James 1:5 promises wisdom to those who ask. Colossians 2:3: in Christ are hidden all the treasures of wisdom. Acts 7:48: the Most High does not dwell in houses made by hands. Revelation 21:22: no temple, for the Lord is its temple.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Solomon’s prayer for wisdom for a specific decision you face.

Remember that you are now a temple of the Spirit. Think about how you care for your body and your thoughts.

Offer your best skills to God, whatever they are.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God for wisdom to lead those he has given you.
- Marvel that heaven cannot contain him and yet he hears you.
- Ask him to teach you to honor him in your work.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 77

"If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land."

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

DAY 535 · WEEK 77

2 Chronicles 5:1-7:22

The Temple dedicated; the glory fills the house

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 5:1-7:22. The ark is brought into the temple, the glory cloud fills the house, Solomon prays, and fire falls from heaven. Then God answers with a promise and a warning. Pay special attention to 7:14.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The temple is complete, and the ark is brought in. The Levite singers stand with cymbals, harps, and lyres, along with 120 priests blowing trumpets. At the moment they begin to praise, God's glory fills the house. Solomon then dedicates the temple with a long prayer. God appears again and gives a conditional promise to Israel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It was the duty of the trumpeters and singers to make themselves heard in unison in praise and thanksgiving to the LORD" (5:13).
2. "For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever" (5:13).
3. "The house, the house of the LORD, was filled with a cloud" (5:13).
4. "The glory of the LORD filled the house of God" (5:14).
5. "But will God indeed dwell with man on the earth? Behold, heaven and the highest heaven cannot contain you; how much less this house that I have built!" (6:18).
6. "And listen to the pleas of your servant and of your people Israel, when they pray toward this place" (6:21).
7. "When the people of Israel… fire came down from heaven and consumed the burnt offering and the sacrifices" (7:1).

8 “If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land” (7:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The dedication scene is built on musical praise and visible glory. At the moment the singers sound as “one voice” praising the LORD with the refrain, “For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever,” the cloud fills the house. The priests could not stand to minister because of the glory. This repeats the experience at the tabernacle in Exodus 40. God accepts the house.

Solomon’s prayer is among the longest in the Bible. He begins with praise, recalls the promise to David, and then asks the central question: “Will God indeed dwell with man on the earth?” He knows the paradox. Then comes a series of petitions: when someone wrongs a neighbor, when the nation is defeated, when there is drought, famine, or plague, when a foreigner comes to pray, when the people go to war, and when they sin and are exiled. For each, Solomon asks: “Hear from heaven.” The temple is a place of prayer for every need. And for the exile, he prays: “If they repent… and pray toward this land, which you gave to their fathers, then hear from heaven.”

That petition is directly answered in chapter 7. Fire falls from heaven, and the people bow and worship. Then, at night, God appears to Solomon and gives the promise that returned exiles needed most: “If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land.” This verse is often quoted out of context, as though about a modern nation. In its original context, it was spoken to Israel about the temple and the land, and it gives the pattern for restoration: humility, prayer, seeking, and repentance. God’s promise is certain. But a warning follows: if they turn away and serve other gods, the temple itself will become a byword.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 9:11-12 says Christ entered once for all into the holy places, by means of his own blood. Matthew 18:20: “Where two or three are gathered in my name, there am I among them.” Acts 2:1-4 describes the Spirit filling the believers like fire. 1 John 1:9: if we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive. James 4:6-10 says to humble yourselves before the Lord. Luke 11:2: “Hallowed be your name.”

STEP 6

Application

Practice the four steps of 7:14: humble yourself, pray, seek his face, and turn from sin.

Pray Solomon's "Hear from heaven" for specific needs of your church and community.

Ask God to fill your gatherings with his presence, not just your plans.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks that his steadfast love endures forever.
- Ask him to fill his house, your church, with his glory.
- Ask him to hear from heaven when you pray.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 77

"If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land."

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

DAY 536 · WEEK 77

Psalm 132

Remember, O LORD, in David's favor

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 132. This psalm recalls David's oath to find a dwelling place for the LORD and the LORD's oath to establish David's line. It echoes 2 Chronicles 6 and 7. Read the two oaths side by side.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 132 is a Song of Ascents, sung by pilgrims on the way up to Jerusalem. It recalls the bringing of the ark to Zion. Verses 8 to 10 are quoted in Solomon's prayer in 2 Chronicles 6:41-42, so it is easy to connect with this week's reading. It celebrates two oaths: David's oath to God, and God's oath to David.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Remember, O LORD, in David's favor, all the hardships he endured" (v. 1).
2. "How he swore to the LORD and vowed to the Mighty One of Jacob" (v. 2).
3. "I will not enter my house or get into my bed, I will not give sleep to my eyes... until I find a place for the LORD" (vv. 3-5).
4. "Let us go to his dwelling place; let us worship at his footstool!" (v. 7).
5. "Arise, O LORD, and go to your resting place, you and the ark of your might" (v. 8).
6. "The LORD swore to David a sure oath from which he will not turn back" (v. 11).
7. "One of the sons of your body I will set on your throne" (v. 11).
8. "This is my resting place forever; here I will dwell, for I have desired it" (v. 14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with David's passion. He could not rest until God had a place. The word "find" suggests a long search; the ark had been scattered for years. This longing for God's presence is the engine of the psalm. For David, a house for himself was nothing if the ark of God remained in a tent.

The pilgrims then go to the place: "Let us go to his dwelling place." They sing, "Arise, O LORD, to your resting place." This was probably sung at the entrance of the ark into the temple. They ask for the priests to be clothed with righteousness and the saints to shout for joy.

Then the psalm turns to God's oath, which is the center. "The LORD swore to David a sure oath from which he will not turn back." God's promise is not a negotiation. It is sworn, which means it does not depend on the performance of David's descendants. Yet it comes with a condition for them: if your sons keep my covenant, their sons will also sit on the throne. The Davidic promise is both unconditional in its ultimate fulfillment and conditional in its enjoyment by each generation. This is exactly the tension the Chronicler resolves: the line may fail, but the promise will not.

Then God speaks about Zion: "This is my resting place forever; here I will dwell, for I have desired it." God desires to dwell with his people. And he promises food for the poor, salvation for the priests, and joy for the saints. The final image is stunning: "There I will make a horn to sprout for David; I have prepared a lamp for my anointed." The horn is a symbol of strength, the lamp of continuing life. The line looks dark, but the lamp is lit. The Chronicler's readers would see it as a promise: a king will come.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 1:69 says God has raised up a horn of salvation in the house of David. John 8:12: "I am the light of the world." Acts 2:30 says David knew God had sworn an oath to set one of his descendants on his throne. Revelation 21:3: the dwelling place of God is with man. Matthew 11:28: "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest." Hebrews 4:9-11 speaks of a Sabbath rest for the people of God.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you long for God's presence as David did. What are you willing to give up for it?

Sing or pray verses 8 to 9 as part of your worship, as the pilgrims did.

Thank God for the "sure oath" of the gospel, which does not depend on your performance.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to remember his covenant.
- Ask him to clothe his priests with righteousness.
- Thank him for making his home among his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 77

"If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land."

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

DAY 537 · WEEK 77

Psalm 135

Praise the name of the LORD in his house

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 135. You read this psalm on Day 488 beside Daniel's idols. Read it now as a hymn of the returned community, who sang it in the rebuilt temple, calling the servants of the LORD to praise.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 135 is made largely of quotations from other parts of Scripture: Exodus, Deuteronomy, and the Psalms. It was a worship song for the second temple, calling the priests and Levites "who stand in the house of the LORD" to praise. It celebrates God's greatness in creation and in history, and it ridicules idols. On Day 488 you read it beside the idols of Babylon. Today, notice how it pulls together the Chronicler's themes: the temple, the Levites, God's choice, and God's mighty acts.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Praise the name of the LORD, give praise, O servants of the LORD, who stand in the house of the LORD" (vv. 1-2).
2. "For the LORD has chosen Jacob for himself, Israel as his own possession" (v. 4).
3. "For I know that the LORD is great, and that our Lord is above all gods" (v. 5).
4. "Whatever the LORD pleases, he does, in heaven and on earth" (v. 6).
5. "He it was who struck down the firstborn of Egypt" (v. 8).
6. "Your name, O LORD, endures forever, your renown, O LORD, throughout all ages" (v. 13).
7. "Those who make them become like them, so do all who trust in them" (v. 18).

8 “O house of Israel, bless the LORD! O house of Aaron, bless the LORD! O house of Levi, bless the LORD!” (vv. 19-20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a collage of Scripture, and that is its point. The worshipers of the second temple did not invent new words. They drew on the Torah and the earlier Psalms, weaving them into a new song. This is how worship grows: from the word of God into the heart of the people.

The first section calls the servants of the LORD to praise. The reason is that the LORD has chosen Jacob. The word “possession” is a treasure, a special possession. Israel is not great, but God chose them, and this is the ground of their joy.

The psalm then looks at God’s power in creation and at his deeds in Egypt. “Whatever the LORD pleases, he does.” He sends lightning with the rain, brings the wind from his storehouses, and strikes down the firstborn of Egypt. He gave Israel the land as a heritage. These are not abstractions but stories, and they are told in order to say: our God acts.

At the center is the contrast with the idols, as in Psalm 115. The language is almost the same, which tells us how deep it ran in the memory of the community. Idols are silver and gold. They have mouths, eyes, ears, but no breath. “Those who make them become like them.” The community that remembered Babylon’s idols had a vivid sense of how empty they were.

The psalm ends by calling the whole community by name: house of Israel, house of Aaron, house of Levi, and “you who fear the LORD.” Each group is told to bless the LORD. It ends where it began: “Blessed be the LORD from Zion, he who dwells in Jerusalem! Praise the LORD!” The point is that the people who worship the living God are alive to him.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 19:5-6 says Israel is God’s treasured possession. 1 Peter 2:9 applies it to the church: “a people for his own possession.” Ephesians 1:4 says he chose us in him before the foundation of the world. Isaiah 44:9-20 mocks idols. Revelation 4:11 says all things were created by his will. Psalm 115:3-8 parallels verses 15 to 18. Colossians 3:16: let the word of Christ dwell in you richly, singing.

STEP 6

Application

Compose a short prayer of praise using only words from Scripture, as the psalmist did.

Thank God that he chose you, not because of anything in you, but out of love.

Notice what in your life might be shaping you into its image. Are you becoming like what you worship?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for choosing you as his own possession.
- Thank him that he is above all gods.
- Ask him to keep you from idols.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 77

"If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land."

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

DAY 538 · WEEK 77

Psalm 136

His steadfast love endures forever

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 136. You read this on Day 489 as a liturgy of God's love beside Daniel's trials. Read it now aloud with a partner if you can, one reading the first line of each verse and the other answering with the refrain. It was probably sung at the temple's dedication.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 136 is the refrain psalm: twenty-six verses, each ending "for his steadfast love endures forever." It is the refrain sung in 2 Chronicles 5:13, 7:3, and 7:6 at the dedication of the temple, and in Ezra 3:11 when the second temple's foundation was laid. This week, you have met the refrain at nearly every turn. Today you read the whole song. On Day 489 you read it against exile. Now read it as the temple's song.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever" (v. 1).
2. "To him who alone does great wonders, for his steadfast love endures forever" (v. 4).
3. "To him who by understanding made the heavens" (v. 5).
4. "To him who spread out the earth above the waters" (v. 6).
5. "To him who struck down the firstborn of Egypt" (v. 10).
6. "And brought Israel out from among them" (v. 11).
7. "It is he who remembered us in our low estate" (v. 23).
8. "He who gives food to all flesh" (v. 25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a story told in a chorus. The first lines call for thanks to the God of gods and Lord of lords. Then it narrates creation: heavens, earth, sun, moon, and stars. Then it moves to the exodus: striking the firstborn of Egypt, dividing the Red Sea, leading the people through the wilderness. Then the conquest: striking down great kings and giving their land as a heritage. Then the final line: "It is he who remembered us in our low estate." The psalm covers creation, redemption, and conquest in a pattern of repeated assurance.

The most important feature is the repetition. "His steadfast love endures forever" appears twenty-six times. A modern reader might wonder why. But the people were not reading silently. They were singing, and one group sang the line while another answered. The refrain became a habit of the heart. Hearing it again and again taught them something that could not be taught in one sentence: God's love does not wear out.

Notice the surprising items in the list of God's deeds. The striking of Egypt's firstborn is in the same breath as creation. For Israel, God's love included his judgment on those who oppressed them. His love is not sentimental. It rescues, and rescue sometimes means defeating the enemy.

Verse 23 is for the exiles: "He remembered us in our low estate." They knew what "low estate" meant. They had been in Babylon and then returned to a small, ruined city. And God remembered. "And rescued us from our foes." The last verse reaches out to all creation: "He who gives food to all flesh." His love covers the whole world.

For the dedication of the temple, no better song could have been chosen. Every item in the list pointed back to the one truth that had held them through everything.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:35-39 asks what can separate us from the love of Christ. 1 John 4:10: "In this is love, not that we have loved God but that he loved us and sent his Son." Lamentations 3:22-23 says the steadfast love of the LORD never ceases. Ephesians 3:17-19 prays that we may know the love of Christ. John 3:16 gives the greatest expression of that love. Psalm 103:11: as high as the heavens are above the earth, so great is his steadfast love.

STEP 6

Application

Read the psalm aloud with someone, and let the refrain sink in.

Write your own “Psalm 136”: a list of ten things God has done for you, each ending with “for his steadfast love endures forever.”

When you struggle with doubt, repeat the refrain.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God for his steadfast love, line by line, in your own words.
- Thank him for his great wonders.
- Thank him for what he has done in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 77

“If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land.”

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

DAY 539 · WEEK 77

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Chronicles 7:14 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land."

2 CHRONICLES 7:14

REST

Meditation

This is one of the most quoted verses in the Old Testament, and it is easy to misuse. So begin with its setting. God is speaking to Solomon, at night, after the temple is dedicated. He is speaking about Israel, the land, and the temple. In its original context, the "land" is the land of Israel. We should not simply apply it to any modern nation, but we can learn the pattern, which is repeated across Scripture.

"If my people who are called by my name." The promise is for a particular people: those who bear God's name. The church is also called by his name. God's concern is first with his own people.

"Humble themselves." This is the first step. The problem is not mainly outside; it begins with pride. Humility is the beginning of any restoration.

“And pray and seek my face.” Prayer is asking. To seek his face is to want God himself, not just his gifts. It is looking for his presence and his favor.

“And turn from their wicked ways.” Repentance is not only sorrow but change. There is a turning around.

“Then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land.” God’s response is threefold: he hears, he forgives, and he heals. Every verb is his gift. We do not heal the land; he does. Our part is to humble, pray, seek, and turn.

Remember that this passage was fulfilled in part under Hezekiah and Josiah. It points toward the greater turning that Christ makes possible. Pray this verse for your church first, then for your community. Begin with yourself.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the end of David’s reign and the beginning of Solomon’s according to the Chronicler. You heard David’s charge to Solomon, “Know the God of your father and serve him with a whole heart,” and his great prayer, “All things come from you, and of your own have we given you.” You watched Solomon ask for wisdom, build the temple on Mount Moriah, and dedicate it as God’s glory filled the house. You heard God’s answer to Solomon’s prayer in 7:14. In Psalm 132, you read the two oaths, David’s to God and God’s to David. In Psalms 135 and 136, you sang the songs of the second temple: the God who chose Israel, who is above all idols, and whose steadfast love endures forever.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

David said, “All things come from you, and of your own have we given you.” How does that change the way you think about your money, time, and talents?

2 Chronicles 7:14 gives four responses: humble, pray, seek, turn. Which is hardest for you right now?

Solomon’s temple is fulfilled in Jesus and in his people. How does it change your daily life to know that God’s Spirit dwells in you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Humble yourself before God and ask him to hear from heaven.

Ask him to forgive sin and heal what is broken.

Thank him for Christ, the true temple.

DAY 540 · WEEK 78

2 Chronicles 8:1-12:16

Solomon's reign; the kingdom divides; Rehoboam

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 84 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 8:1-12:16. Solomon's reign ends, the kingdom divides, and Rehoboam, humbled by Shishak's invasion, repents for a moment. Read for the Chronicler's pattern: seek the LORD and prosper; forsake him and suffer.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Chronicler gives Solomon's reign a glowing finish, with the visit of the queen of Sheba, and omits his sin with foreign wives. He wants his readers to remember the golden age. Then the story turns on Rehoboam, who rejects wise counsel, and the northern tribes break away. From this point, the Chronicler largely follows the kings of Judah, the line of David, and ignores the northern kingdom except where it touches Judah.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And the queen of Sheba said, The report was true that I heard in my own land of your words and of your wisdom" (9:5).
2. "Blessed be the LORD your God, who has delighted in you and set you on his throne" (9:8).
3. "But he abandoned the counsel that the old men gave him" (10:8).
4. "So Israel has been in rebellion against the house of David to this day" (10:19).
5. "The priests and Levites who were in all Israel presented themselves to him from all places" (11:13).
6. "And those who set their hearts to seek the LORD God of Israel came after them from all the tribes of Israel" (11:16).

7. “When Rehoboam had established his kingdom and was strong, he abandoned the law of the LORD, and all Israel with him” (12:1).

8. “And when he humbled himself the wrath of the LORD turned from him, so as not to make a complete destruction” (12:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Chronicler gives the pattern that will recur in every reign. The king and the people either seek the LORD or abandon him, and the results follow. Solomon’s wisdom draws the queen of Sheba from afar. She marvels, and she blesses the LORD. The glory of Solomon’s reign points beyond itself.

Rehoboam shows the reverse. He asks for advice from the elders, who counsel gentleness, and from his young friends, who counsel harshness. He chooses the young men’s counsel and answers the people roughly. The kingdom splits. Notice that the Chronicler says it was “a turn of affairs brought about by God,” to fulfill his word. Even human folly is under God’s rule.

The Levites and priests leave the north, and many from all the tribes who “set their hearts to seek the LORD” come to Jerusalem. This is a key idea: the true Israel was where God’s worship was. Jeroboam had appointed his own priests for the high places and golden calves. The faithful choose to follow God and leave their land and property behind.

When Rehoboam is established and strong, he forsakes the law, and Egypt’s Shishak comes up against Jerusalem. A prophet explains: “You abandoned me, so I have abandoned you.” The leaders humble themselves, saying, “The LORD is righteous.” God relents in part. Judah will serve Shishak “that they may know the difference between serving me and serving the kings of the countries.” The chapter ends with a verdict: Rehoboam “did evil, for he did not set his heart to seek the LORD.”

Contrast this with Ezra, who “set his heart to study the law.” The heart is the central matter.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 12:42 says the queen of the South will rise at the judgment, “for she came from the ends of the earth to hear the wisdom of Solomon, and behold, something greater than Solomon is here.” Proverbs 11:14: in an abundance of counselors there is safety. James 4:6: God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble. Hebrews 11:25 notes Moses choosing to share ill-treatment with God’s people. 1 Kings 12 records the split.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you are tempted to take the advice that is easy instead of the advice that is wise. Seek counsel from someone older and wiser.

Notice the “set your heart to seek the LORD” language and ask whether your heart is set.

When you fail, remember Rehoboam’s brief humbling and God’s mercy.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to set your heart to seek him.
- Ask him to give you humility to listen to wise counsel.
- Ask him to help you return when you fail.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 78

“For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him.”

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

DAY 541 · WEEK 78

2 Chronicles 13:1-16:14

Abijah, Asa, Chronicles' portrait of reform

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 70 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 13:1-16:14. Abijah speaks to Jeroboam, Asa seeks the LORD and has peace, and then Asa relies on Syria and on physicians and not the LORD. Watch how his story changes.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Abijah, king of Judah, faces Jeroboam's much larger army. Then his son Asa begins a long reign with a great reform and thirty-five years of peace. But in his later years, he trusts in a human alliance instead of God, rejects the prophet, and dies after seeking help from physicians only. The Chronicler makes him an example of a good start and a poor finish.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "God is with us at our head, and his priests with their battle trumpets to sound the call to battle against you" (13:12).
2. "And the men of Judah cried out. And when the men of Judah shouted, God defeated Jeroboam" (13:15).
3. "Thus the men of Israel were subdued at that time, and the men of Judah prevailed, because they relied on the LORD" (13:18).
4. "And Asa did what was good and right in the eyes of the LORD his God" (14:2).
5. "LORD, there is none like you to help, between the mighty and the weak. Help us, O LORD our God, for we rely on you" (14:11).
6. "The LORD is with you while you are with him. If you seek him, he will be found by you" (15:2).

7. “For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him” (16:9).

8. “Yet even in his disease he did not seek the LORD, but sought help from the physicians” (16:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Chronicler tells the stories as case studies in dependence. Abijah is outnumbered two to one and ambushed. But he stands on a hill and speaks to Jeroboam, reminding him of God’s covenant with David and of Jeroboam’s golden calves. When the battle is joined, Judah cries out to the LORD, the priests blow trumpets, and God routs the enemy. “They relied on the LORD.” The word means to lean.

Asa’s first years are the model. He removes the foreign altars and high places, commands Judah to seek the LORD, and gets peace. When a million Ethiopians come against him, he prays one of the best prayers of the Bible: “LORD, there is none like you to help, between the mighty and the weak.” God gives victory.

The prophet Azariah then gives the principle that summarizes the Chronicler’s theology: “The LORD is with you while you are with him. If you seek him, he will be found by you, but if you forsake him, he will forsake you.” Asa and the people enter a covenant to seek the LORD with all their heart and soul, and “he was found by them.” He even deposes his own grandmother for idolatry.

But in the thirty-sixth year, Baasha of Israel comes against him, and Asa takes the temple’s silver and gold to hire the king of Syria. It works, politically. Then the seer Hanani rebukes him: “Because you relied on the king of Syria, and did not rely on the LORD your God… the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless.” Asa’s response is to throw the prophet into prison and oppress some of the people.

The saddest note: when he is diseased in his feet, he “did not seek the LORD, but sought help from the physicians.” The point is not that doctors are wrong, but that he sought only them. He had lost the habit of dependence.

STEP 5

Connection

Proverbs 3:5-6: “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding.” Jeremiah 17:5-8 contrasts those who trust in man with those who trust in the LORD. 2 Corinthians 12:9: “My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in

weakness." Philippians 3:13-14 speaks of pressing on. Hebrews 3:14 warns that we share in Christ if we hold our original confidence firm to the end. John 15:5: "Apart from me you can do nothing."

STEP 6

Application

Pray Asa's prayer: "There is none like you to help, between the mighty and the weak."

Think about a place in your life where you rely on human solutions only. Bring God into it.

Pray for finishing well. Ask God to keep you dependent on him in the later seasons of life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God that you rely on him, not on your own strength.
- Thank him that there is none like him to help the weak.
- Ask him to keep you from turning to others first.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 78

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him."

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

DAY 542 · WEEK 78

2 Chronicles 17:1-20:37

Jehoshaphat, faithfulness and compromise

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 92 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 17:1-20:37. Jehoshaphat sends teachers throughout Judah, makes an unwise alliance with Ahab, and then, when a vast army comes, leads the nation in prayer. Read 20:1-30 closely.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jehoshaphat is one of the Chronicler's favorite kings. He sends officials, Levites, and priests with the Book of the Law to teach in every city of Judah. He appoints judges. But he also allies himself with the wicked Ahab. When Moab, Ammon, and others come against him, he proclaims a fast and leads Judah in a great prayer. The result is one of the most remarkable victories in Scripture.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And they taught in Judah, having the Book of the Law of the LORD with them" (17:9).
2. "Should you help the wicked and love those who hate the LORD?" (19:2).
3. "Consider what you do, for you judge not for man but for the LORD" (19:6).
4. "Then Jehoshaphat was afraid and set his face to seek the LORD, and proclaimed a fast throughout all Judah" (20:3).
5. "O our God, will you not execute judgment on them? For we are powerless against this great horde that is coming against us. We do not know what to do, but our eyes are on you" (20:12).
6. "Do not be afraid and do not be dismayed at this great horde, for the battle is not yours but God's" (20:15).

7. “Believe in the LORD your God, and you will be established; believe his prophets, and you will succeed” (20:20).

8. “And when they began to sing and praise, the LORD set an ambush against the men of Ammon, Moab, and Mount Seir” (20:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jehoshaphat’s best moment is when he sends teachers. Notice the method: officials, Levites, and priests go through the cities “having the Book of the Law of the LORD with them.” Spiritual health comes through teaching God’s word. The result was that the fear of the LORD fell on neighboring kingdoms, and they did not make war against Judah.

His worst moment is his alliance with Ahab. The prophet Micaiah is the one true voice against four hundred false prophets, and Jehoshaphat sees the king of Israel struck and nearly dies himself. The prophet Jehu asks, “Should you help the wicked and love those who hate the LORD?” But he adds that there is some good in him. God’s grace works in people with mixed records.

Then the great crisis arrives. A vast army comes from beyond the Dead Sea. The king is afraid, and the fear drives him to God, not away from him. He gathers the whole nation, including “their little ones, their wives, and their children,” and prays. His prayer begins with who God is, “You rule over all the kingdoms of the nations,” recalls God’s promises about the temple, and then admits the truth: “We are powerless… We do not know what to do, but our eyes are on you.” That sentence is one of the best prayers a person can pray.

God answers through a Levite named Jahaziel: “The battle is not yours but God’s.” The next morning, Jehoshaphat appoints singers to go before the army, praising “for his steadfast love endures forever.” When they began to sing, God set ambushes, and the enemy destroyed each other. Judah collected plunder for three days and gathered in the Valley of Beracah, “blessing.” The nation returned to Jerusalem with harps, lyres, and trumpets.

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 6:12: we do not wrestle against flesh and blood. Romans 8:31: if God is for us, who can be against us? 2 Corinthians 4:8: “We are afflicted in every way, but not crushed… perplexed, but not driven to despair.” Acts 16:25-26 shows Paul and Silas singing in prison. 1 Samuel 17:47: “The battle is the LORD’s.” Isaiah 26:3: you keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you.

STEP 6

Application

Use Jehoshaphat's prayer the next time you face something beyond you: "I do not know what to do, but my eyes are on you."

Try praising God in the middle of a hard situation, before you see the answer.

Be careful with your closest alliances, and ask whether they pull you toward or away from God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you cannot manage, and say, "My eyes are on you."

Thank him that the battle is his.

Ask him to teach you to worship before you see the victory.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 78

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him."

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

DAY 543 · WEEK 78

2 Chronicles 21:1-24:27

Jehoram, Athaliah, Joash, the throne preserved

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 89 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 21:1-24:27. Jehoram and Ahaziah lead Judah into evil, Athaliah usurps the throne, and young Joash is rescued and crowned. Joash starts well under the priest Jehoiada and then falls. Watch how the Chronicler explains the change.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jehoshaphat's alliance with Ahab leads to the marriage of his son Jehoram to Athaliah, Ahab's daughter. The consequence is tragic. Jehoram kills his brothers, Ahaziah is killed, and Athaliah slaughters the royal family except for one baby, Joash. The line of David hangs by a thread. This is the low point of Judah's early history.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And he walked in the way of the kings of Israel, as the house of Ahab had done, for the daughter of Ahab was his wife" (21:6).
2. "Yet the LORD was not willing to destroy the house of David, because of the covenant that he had made with David" (21:7).
3. "Jehosheba… took Joash the son of Ahaziah and stole him away from among the king's sons who were being put to death" (22:11).
4. "Behold, the king's son! Let him reign, as the LORD spoke concerning the sons of David" (23:3).
5. "And Joash did what was right in the eyes of the LORD all the days of Jehoiada the priest" (24:2).

6. “But after the death of Jehoiada the officials of Judah came and paid homage to the king” (24:17).
7. “The Spirit of God clothed Zechariah the son of Jehoiada the priest, and he stood above the people” (24:20).
8. “Thus Joash the king did not remember the kindness that Jehoiada, Zechariah’s father, had shown him, but killed his son” (24:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 21 shows how a bad alliance bears bitter fruit. Jehoram marries Ahab’s daughter and imports Baal worship. He murders his six brothers, and God sends an Edomite revolt and a Philistine and Arab raid. Elijah sends a letter of judgment. He dies in agony of the bowels, and “no one desired his departure.” It is a terrible epitaph.

Yet the Chronicler adds a note of mercy: “The LORD was not willing to destroy the house of David, because of the covenant.” God’s faithfulness to his promise is bigger than the faithlessness of the kings. And at the lowest moment, when Athaliah murders the heirs of David, God has a baby hidden. Jehosheba, the king’s daughter and wife of the priest Jehoiada, saves Joash and hides him in the temple for six years. The promise to David depended on a woman’s courage.

Jehoiada then stages the coup. He gathers the Levites and the commanders, brings out the boy king, and crowns him. The priest makes a covenant between God, the king, and the people. The people rejoice, and the city is quiet. Athaliah is put to death, and the Baal altar is torn down.

Joash starts well, repairing the temple with a collection from the people. But Jehoiada dies at 130, and everything changes. The officials come and persuade the king, and “they abandoned the house of the LORD… and served the Asherim and the idols.” Joash’s faith had been a borrowed faith, propped up by his mentor. When God sends prophets, the king responds by having Zechariah, the priest’s son, stoned in the temple court. “May the LORD see and avenge.”

The tragedy of Joash is that he never made the faith his own. The lesson is to build a faith that stands even when the people who first taught you are gone.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Timothy 1:5 praises the faith that dwelt in Timothy's grandmother and mother, and now in him. Matthew 23:35 refers to the blood of Zechariah, who was killed between the temple and the altar. Hebrews 3:12: "Take care, brothers, lest there be in any of you an evil, unbelieving heart." 2 Corinthians 6:14: do not be unequally yoked. Jude 24: "Now to him who is able to keep you from stumbling."

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your faith depends on a person or a community more than on your own walk with God. Take a step to own it.

Thank someone who played the role of Jehoiada in your life.

Be a Jehoiada to a young person: protect, teach, and pray.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his faithfulness when his people fail.

Thank him for preserving David's line.

Ask him to keep you from taking his patience for granted.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 78

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him."

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

DAY 544 · WEEK 78

2 Chronicles 25:1-28:27

Amaziah, Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, mixed faithfulness

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 25:1-28:27. Amaziah, Uzziah, Jotham, and Ahaz take the throne in turn. Look for the word “strong,” and for what happens when strength leads to pride.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These four kings cover about 100 years. Amaziah starts well and ends with idolatry. Uzziah is one of the most successful kings, but he oversteps in the temple and is struck with leprosy. Jotham is faithful. Ahaz is among the worst, closing the temple and sacrificing his own children. Isaiah’s early ministry takes place in this period, which you read in Unit 12.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “And he did what was right in the eyes of the LORD, yet not with a whole heart” (25:2).
2. “The LORD is able to give you much more than this” (25:9).
3. “And he did what was right in the eyes of the LORD… And as long as he sought the LORD, God made him prosper” (26:4-5).
4. “And his fame spread far, for he was marvelously helped, till he was strong” (26:15).
5. “But when he was strong, he grew proud, to his destruction” (26:16).
6. “So Jotham became mighty, because he ordered his ways before the LORD his God” (27:6).
7. “For the LORD humbled Judah because of Ahaz king of Israel, for he had made Judah act sinfully” (28:19).
8. “In the time of his distress he became yet more faithless to the LORD” (28:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Amaziah's description is chilling: he did what was right, "yet not with a whole heart." He listens to a prophet when it costs him money, dismissing 100,000 hired soldiers from Israel because "the LORD is able to give you much more than this." But after defeating Edom, he brings home their gods and worships them. When a prophet confronts him, he threatens the prophet. A partial faith ends in ruin.

Uzziah's story is the most important in this section. He reigned for 52 years and "as long as he sought the LORD, God made him prosper." He built towers, dug cisterns, organized a large army, and developed new weapons. His fame spread. "He was marvelously helped, till he was strong." And then the dangerous line: "But when he was strong, he grew proud, to his destruction." He went into the temple to burn incense, which was the priest's job. When eighty priests confronted him, he raged. And leprosy broke out on his forehead. He lived in isolation the rest of his life. The point is stark: success, apart from humility, destroys. This is the same Uzziah in whose death year Isaiah saw the LORD (Isaiah 6:1).

Jotham is a quiet counterexample. "He ordered his ways before the LORD his God." The word "ordered" means to establish firmly. No dramatic event, just steady faithfulness, and he "became mighty."

Ahaz is the opposite: he made metal images for Baals, burned his children, and shut the temple doors. When Assyria pressed him, he sent them the temple treasures. Verse 22 says, "In the time of his distress he became yet more faithless." Hardship should drive us to God. For Ahaz it drove him away.

STEP 5

Connection

Proverbs 16:18: "Pride goes before destruction, and a haughty spirit before a fall." James 4:6: God gives grace to the humble. Luke 18:14: "Everyone who exalts himself will be humbled." Isaiah 6:1-5 records the vision that came in the year Uzziah died. Hebrews 7:26-27 says Jesus is the high priest we need. Romans 12:3: do not think of yourself more highly than you ought.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether any success in your life has made you less dependent on God.

Be like Jotham: order your ways before the LORD, steadily and quietly.

Notice where you are serving God "not with a whole heart," and ask him to unify your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God for a whole heart.

Ask him to keep you humble when you are strong.

Ask him to drive you to him, not away, when you are distressed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 78

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him."

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

DAY 545 · WEEK 78

2 Chronicles 29:1-32:33

Hezekiah's great reform, Temple worship restored

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 29:1-32:33. Hezekiah reopens the temple, restores the Passover, and trusts God when Sennacherib invades. Read for the extraordinary Passover, where the whole kingdom seeks the LORD, and note 30:18-20.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Hezekiah is the Chronicler's greatest reformer. He begins in the first month of his first year, opening the doors of the temple. Unlike the account in Kings, which emphasizes Sennacherib's invasion, the Chronicler spends three chapters on the temple's cleansing and the great Passover. You read the Sennacherib story in Isaiah in Unit 12. Here it is brief, and in this book it is the reward of faithfulness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In the first year of his reign, in the first month, he opened the doors of the house of the LORD and repaired them" (29:3).
2. "For our fathers have been unfaithful and have done what was evil in the sight of the LORD our God" (29:6).
3. "Be not like your fathers and your brothers, who were faithless to the LORD" (30:7).
4. "But some men of Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun humbled themselves and came to Jerusalem" (30:11).
5. "May the good LORD pardon everyone who sets his heart to seek God, the LORD, the God of his fathers, even though not according to the sanctuary's rules of cleanness" (30:18-19).

6. “And the LORD heard Hezekiah and healed the people” (30:20).
7. “So there was great joy in Jerusalem, for since the time of Solomon… there had been nothing like this” (30:26).
8. “Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid or dismayed… for there is one greater with us than with him” (32:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Hezekiah acts at once. In the first month of his first year, he reopens the temple, and the priests spend sixteen days cleansing it. His words to the Levites: “Do not now be negligent, for the LORD has chosen you to stand in his presence.” Then the temple is rededicated with burnt offerings and with singing, “the song to the LORD began also, and the trumpets.” The people bring thank offerings, so many that the priests need help.

Then he does something unusual: he invites the northern tribes, now in ruin under Assyria, to come to Jerusalem to keep the Passover. Couriers go throughout Israel, from Beersheba to Dan. Some laugh at them. But others humble themselves and come. The result is a massive celebration, for two weeks, with joy that Jerusalem had not seen since Solomon.

One detail is gracious. Many who came had not purified themselves according to the rules. Hezekiah prays: “May the good LORD pardon everyone who sets his heart to seek God, even though not according to the sanctuary’s rules of cleanness.” And the LORD heard and healed the people. God cares about the heart above ritual precision, though he does not dismiss ritual.

When Sennacherib invades, the Chronicler tells it in a few verses. Hezekiah strengthens the walls, digs a tunnel to bring water into the city, and encourages the people: “With him is an arm of flesh, but with us is the LORD our God, to help us and to fight our battles.” He and Isaiah cry to heaven, and an angel destroys the Assyrian army. The chapter ends with a hint of pride in Hezekiah’s heart, which he repents of, and then notes his prosperity. “God left him to himself, in order to test him and to know all that was in his heart.” Even the best king is human.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 4:16: “Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace.” 1 Corinthians 5:7-8: Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed. Luke 15:20 shows the father welcoming the returning son. Joel 2:12-13 calls for returning with all your heart. 1 John 4:4: “He who is in you is greater than he who is in the world.” Romans 10:1-3 speaks of zeal for God, rightly understood.

STEP 6

Application

Do the first thing first: what is one area where God's "house" in your life needs to be cleaned out and opened?

Invite someone who is far from God to come with you to worship.

When you fear, remember: "There is one greater with us than with him."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to pardon everyone who sets their heart to seek him, including you.

Ask him to help you cleanse what is unclean in your life.

Thank him for healing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 78

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him."

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

DAY 546 · WEEK 78

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Chronicles 16:9 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him."

2 CHRONICLES 16:9

REST

Meditation

This verse was spoken as a rebuke to King Asa, but it is full of encouragement. It was meant to say, "You could have had so much more help if you had trusted me." For us, it is an invitation.

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro." The image is of God's active attention. His eyes are not still. They run, like a scout surveying the land. The LORD is looking, searching, always watching. Nothing is hidden from him. For those who want to hide, this is a threat. For those who are seeking him, it is a comfort.

"Throughout the whole earth." His watch covers the entire world, not just Israel. No place is outside his sight. No believer is forgotten, however remote.

“To give strong support.” This is what he is looking for: someone to help. The word means to strengthen or make firm. He is not scanning in order to catch people out but to find those he can support. God is looking for people to help.

“To those whose heart is blameless toward him.” The condition is a heart that is whole, undivided, and loyal. “Blameless” does not mean sinless. Asa was no angel, and neither was David. It means a heart that is fully turned toward him, that does not divide its trust. God looks for those whose reliance is wholly on him.

When you feel alone, small, or unnoticed, remember that God’s eyes are running through the whole earth with a purpose: to help you. Give him a heart that is completely his.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed the kings of Judah through the Chronicler’s eyes. You saw Solomon’s glory fade into Rehoboam’s folly, and the kingdom divide. You watched Asa cry out to the LORD against a million Ethiopians and then rely on Syria and doctors in his old age. You saw Jehoshaphat teach the law, make an unwise alliance, and then lead the nation in prayer: “We do not know what to do, but our eyes are on you.” You followed the tragedy of Athaliah and the rescue of baby Joash, then Joash’s fall after Jehoiada’s death. You read of Uzziah’s pride and Jotham’s steady faithfulness, and Hezekiah’s reform and Passover. The Chronicler’s lesson is clear: seek the LORD and you will find him; forsake him and he will forsake you.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Chronicler repeats the word “seek” again and again. What does seeking the LORD look like in your daily rhythm?

Asa began well and ended poorly. What practices might help you to finish well?

Hezekiah prayed, “May the good LORD pardon everyone who sets his heart to seek God.” How does the gospel assure us of that pardon?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God for a heart that is wholly his.

Thank him that his eyes run to and fro to strengthen the blameless.

Rest in him.

DAY 547 · WEEK 79

2 Chronicles 33:1-36:23

Manasseh's repentance; Josiah; exile; Cyrus's decree

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 101 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Chronicles 33:1-36:23. Manasseh sins, repents, and is restored. Josiah finds the Book of the Law. Then the kings fall one by one, and the temple is burned. The book ends with a decree of Cyrus. Read the final verses twice.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The last four chapters of Chronicles trace the fall of Judah. Manasseh is the worst king, and the Chronicler tells a story found nowhere else: his repentance in Babylon. Josiah's reform is the last great revival. Then come four weak kings, the siege, and the exile. The book closes not with defeat but with an invitation: "Let him go up." It ends where Ezra begins.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Manasseh led Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem astray, to do more evil than the nations" (33:9).
2. "And when he was in distress, he entreated the favor of the LORD his God and humbled himself greatly before the God of his fathers" (33:12).
3. "Then Manasseh knew that the LORD was God" (33:13).
4. "And Josiah… while he was still a boy, began to seek the God of David his father" (34:3).
5. "Hilkiah the priest found the Book of the Law of the LORD given through Moses" (34:14).
6. "Because your heart was tender and you humbled yourself before God" (34:27).
7. "But they kept mocking the messengers of God, despising his words and scoffing at his prophets, until the wrath of the LORD rose against his people, until there was no remedy" (36:16).

8 “Whoever is among you of all his people, may the LORD his God be with him. Let him go up” (36:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Manasseh reigned for 55 years, the longest of any king. He rebuilt high places, set up altars to Baal in the temple, practiced sorcery, and sacrificed his sons. He led the people to do “more evil than the nations.” The Chronicler tells what Kings did not: when the Assyrians took Manasseh in hooks and bronze fetters to Babylon, “he entreated the favor of the LORD his God and humbled himself greatly.” And God “was moved by his entreaty and heard his plea and brought him again to Jerusalem.” “Then Manasseh knew that the LORD was God.” This is one of the great stories of grace in the Old Testament. If Manasseh could be forgiven, anyone can.

Josiah was eight when he began to reign, and at sixteen he began to seek God. At twenty he began purging the land of idols. At twenty-six, while repairing the temple, they found the Book of the Law. When it was read, he tore his clothes. The prophetess Huldah said disaster was coming, but because he humbled himself, he would be gathered in peace. His Passover was the greatest since Samuel. Then, strangely, he is killed at Megiddo after ignoring a warning from Pharaoh Neco, “from the mouth of God.”

After Josiah, four kings fall quickly: Jehoahaz, Jehoiakim, Jehoiachin, and Zedekiah. The key verses are 36:15-16: God sent messengers again and again, “because he had compassion on his people.” But they mocked and despised. “Until there was no remedy.” Babylon burns the temple, breaks down the wall, and carries off the people. The land enjoys its Sabbaths for seventy years, as Jeremiah said.

The book ends with a decree from Cyrus, the same words that open Ezra. It is an open ending. The Hebrew Bible places Chronicles last, so it ends with a call: “Let him go up.” The story invites its readers to return. That is how the Old Testament closes.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 15:11-24 tells the story of the prodigal son who comes to himself and returns. 1 Timothy 1:15-16: Paul, the foremost of sinners, received mercy as an example. 2 Peter 3:9: “The Lord is not slow to fulfill his promise… but is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish.” Romans 5:20: “Where sin increased, grace abounded all the more.” Matthew 11:28 invites the weary to come. John 14:2-3: “I go to prepare a place for you.”

STEP 6

Application

Remember Manasseh when you feel too sinful to be forgiven, or when someone you love seems beyond reach.

Pray for someone you have given up on, that God would humble them and bring them home.

Read the last verse of Chronicles aloud: “Let him go up.” Hear it as an invitation to come home to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that no one is beyond his mercy.
- Ask him to give you a heart that returns to him quickly.
- Pray for someone far from him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 79

“Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster.”

JOEL 2:13

DAY 548 · WEEK 79

Joel 1:1-2:32

The locust plague; the Spirit poured out, Pentecost foretold

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joel 1:1-2:32. A plague of locusts becomes a picture of the coming day of the LORD. Joel calls for repentance, and the LORD promises restoration and the outpouring of his Spirit. Read 2:12-14 and 2:28-32 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Joel's date is uncertain. Many place him in the post-exilic period, which fits the focus on the temple, priests, and elders and the lack of a king. He writes after a devastating plague of locusts and a drought. He uses it as a warning and a sign: if a locust swarm is this terrible, think of the day of the LORD. The book is short and its main message is sharp: return to the LORD, and he will restore.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "What the cutting locust left, the swarming locust has eaten" (1:4).
2. "Wake up, you drunkards, and weep" (1:5).
3. "Put on sackcloth and lament, you priests" (1:13).
4. "Alas for the day! For the day of the LORD is near" (1:15).
5. "Yet even now, declares the LORD, return to me with all your heart, with fasting, with weeping, and with mourning" (2:12).
6. "And rend your hearts and not your garments" (2:13).
7. "For he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love" (2:13).
8. "I will restore to you the years that the swarming locust has eaten" (2:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book opens with an ugly scene. Locusts have stripped the land. Grain, wine, and oil are cut off. The priests cannot offer sacrifices because there is nothing to offer. Even the animals groan. Joel tells the people to look at this and to pass it on to their children. It is a living picture of God's judgment.

Then Joel sees something more. The locusts are a shadow of a greater army, the day of the LORD. "Blow a trumpet in Zion." Chapter 2 describes an unstoppable army before which the earth quakes and the sun and moon grow dark. "The day of the LORD is great and very awesome; who can endure it?"

And then comes one of the sweetest turns in the Old Testament: "Yet even now." Even now, with all of this, the door is open. "Return to me with all your heart." The word for "return" is the main word for repentance. And the repentance is not external: "Rend your hearts and not your garments." Tearing clothes was the visible sign of grief. God asks for the inside to be torn.

The reason to return is God himself. "He is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love." This is the same description you met in Nehemiah 9 and Psalm 145. "And he relents over disaster." The fast, assembly, and prayers that follow are marked by hope: "Who knows whether he will not turn and relent?"

God answers. He is jealous for his land and pities his people. He promises grain, wine, and oil, and then: "I will restore to you the years that the swarming locust has eaten." The lost years are not just forgotten; they are repaid. And the great promise follows: "I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh." Sons, daughters, old men, young men, even servants. This is the most important promise of the book, and it is fulfilled at Pentecost.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 2:16-21: Peter quotes Joel 2:28-32 on the day of Pentecost. Romans 10:13: "Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved." Luke 15:20: the father runs to the returning son. 2 Corinthians 7:10: godly grief produces repentance. Psalm 51:17: a broken and contrite heart, O God, you will not despise. Revelation 9:1-11 uses locust imagery for the final judgment.

STEP 6

Application

Where do you need to "return with all your heart"? Confess it to God.

Ask what your religion looks like on the outside only. Pray that God would tear your heart, not just your garment.

Trust God to restore “the years the locust has eaten” in your life: the seasons you feel were wasted.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Return to God with all your heart, and tell him what it means.

Thank him that he is gracious, merciful, and slow to anger.

Ask him to pour out his Spirit.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 79

“Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster.”

JOEL 2:13

DAY 549 · WEEK 79

Joel 3:1-21

Judgment on the nations; the LORD dwells in Zion

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Joel 3:1-21 (in some Bibles, Joel 2:28-3:21). The LORD gathers the nations for judgment, and the book ends with a vision of a fountain from the LORD's house. Read it as the final answer to the locusts.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Joel's last chapter looks forward to the final day. The LORD will judge the nations for how they treated his people, and his own people will dwell in safety. The language is vivid, with images of a valley of decision and a fountain flowing from the temple. It points past the post-exilic community to the end of history.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For behold, in those days and at that time, when I restore the fortunes of Judah and Jerusalem" (3:1).
2. "I will gather all the nations and bring them down to the Valley of Jehoshaphat" (3:2).
3. "Beat your plowshares into swords, and your pruning hooks into spears" (3:10).
4. "Multitudes, multitudes in the valley of decision! For the day of the LORD is near in the valley of decision" (3:14).
5. "The sun and the moon are darkened, and the stars withdraw their shining" (3:15).
6. "But the LORD is a refuge to his people, a stronghold to the people of Israel" (3:16).
7. "So you shall know that I am the LORD your God, who dwells in Zion, my holy mountain" (3:17).

8 “And a fountain shall come forth from the house of the LORD and water the Valley of Shittim” (3:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Joel moves from the locusts to the end of the world. God promises to “restore the fortunes of Judah and Jerusalem,” language like Psalm 126. Then he will gather the nations to the Valley of Jehoshaphat, a name meaning “the LORD judges.” There he will judge them for scattering his people and dividing the land, and for selling the children of Israel as slaves.

This section is hard to read, because it describes judgment. But it contains a fundamental truth. God sees injustice and will set it right. For those who are oppressed, this is good news. The prayer for justice is answered. The line “Beat your plowshares into swords” is an inversion of the later promise in Isaiah 2:4 and Micah 4:3, where swords are beaten into plowshares. Here, the nations are summoned to war and are met by God.

The “valley of decision” is the place where judgment is decided. The phrase can mean the decision God makes, not our decision. Still, the image captures the seriousness of the moment. Everyone will stand before the Judge. The sun and moon darken, and the LORD roars from Zion. Yet “the LORD is a refuge to his people, a stronghold to the people of Israel.” The same event that terrifies his enemies shelters his people.

The book ends with restoration. The mountains drip sweet wine, the hills flow with milk, and the streambeds run with water. A fountain flows from the house of the LORD. Egypt and Edom will be desolate, but Judah will be inhabited forever. “The LORD dwells in Zion.” That final sentence is the book’s answer to the locusts. The land will be restored, and God will be with his people.

The fountain from the temple is a thread through the whole Bible, from Eden’s river to Ezekiel 47 to Revelation 22.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 22:1-2 shows the river of the water of life flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb. John 7:37-38: “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink.” Isaiah 2:4 and Micah 4:3 invert the swords and plowshares. Matthew 25:31-46 describes the judgment of the nations. Revelation 14:14-20 uses the harvest image from Joel 3:13. Romans 12:19: “Vengeance is mine, I will repay, says the Lord.”

STEP 6

Application

Pray for those who suffer injustice, trusting God to judge rightly.

Remember that the same day that is terrifying to enemies is a refuge for those who trust in the LORD.

Drink from the fountain: spend time in worship, asking Christ to satisfy your thirst.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he judges rightly and is a refuge to his people.

Ask him to make you ready for his day.

Ask him to let his fountain flow from his house.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 79

"Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster."

JOEL 2:13

DAY 550 · WEEK 79

Obadiah 1:1-21

Edom falls, God defends his people

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Obadiah (one chapter, 21 verses). This is the shortest book in the Old Testament. It is a prophecy against Edom, Israel's brother nation, for the pride and violence shown to Judah. Read it in one sitting.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Edom descended from Esau, Jacob's twin brother. The two nations had a history of rivalry. When Babylon destroyed Jerusalem in 586 BC, Edom stood by, gloated, and even took part, looting and handing over fugitives. Obadiah's prophecy was likely given soon after. Psalm 137:7 and Lamentations 4:21 also remember Edom's betrayal. The book answers a question: will God let this stand?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The pride of your heart has deceived you, you who live in the clefts of the rock" (v. 3).
2. "Though you soar aloft like the eagle… from there I will bring you down, declares the LORD" (v. 4).
3. "Because of the violence done to your brother Jacob, shame shall cover you" (v. 10).
4. "On the day that you stood aloof, on the day that strangers carried off his wealth" (v. 11).
5. "You should not gloat over the day of your brother in the day of his misfortune" (v. 12).
6. "You should not enter the gate of my people in the day of their calamity" (v. 13).
7. "For the day of the LORD is near upon all the nations. As you have done, it shall be done to you" (v. 15).
8. "And the kingdom shall be the LORD's" (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Edom's capital Sela, "the rock," was built in the cliffs of the mountains, in a nearly impregnable position. The Edomites thought they were safe: "Who will bring me down to the ground?" Obadiah says God will. Pride has deceived them. No place is high enough to escape God's reach.

The chief charge is against Edom's treatment of Judah. Verses 10 to 14 lay out a series of failures, each introduced by "you should not." Edom stood aloof when strangers invaded. It gloated, rejoiced, boasted, entered the gate, looted, and cut off the fugitives. This is not a case of ordinary rivalry. It is a betrayal of kin. And that is what makes it worse. A brother stands by while his brother is attacked.

Notice what is condemned: standing aloof counts as a sin. "On the day that you stood aloof… you were like one of them." Passive indifference is complicity. Gloating over the misfortune of someone else is a serious sin. Proverbs 24:17-18 says, "Do not rejoice when your enemy falls."

God's judgment is described by the principle of reciprocity: "As you have done, it shall be done to you." The proud will be brought low.

But the book does not end in judgment alone. It ends with a vision of deliverance: "On Mount Zion there shall be those who escape, and it shall be holy." Jacob will possess his own. "Saviors shall go up to Mount Zion to rule Mount Esau, and the kingdom shall be the LORD's." This final sentence is the aim of the whole prophecy: God's kingdom will prevail, and all pride will fall before it.

Obadiah is a reminder that God sees how we treat others, especially when they fall.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 25:41-45 says that what we do or fail to do for the least of these, we do or fail to do for Christ. Luke 10:30-37 shows the priest and Levite who passed by on the other side. Proverbs 24:17: "Do not rejoice when your enemy falls." James 4:6: God opposes the proud. Revelation 11:15: "The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ." 1 Corinthians 12:26: if one member suffers, all suffer together.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a person whose downfall you secretly enjoyed. Confess it, and pray for them.

Ask whether you have “stood aloof” when someone in your family, church, or community was in trouble.

Be on guard against the pride of security, the sense that nothing can touch you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to humble the pride of your heart.

Ask him to keep you from gloating over another’s misfortune.

Ask him to give you a heart that grieves with those who grieve.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 79

“Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster.”

JOEL 2:13

DAY 551 · WEEK 79

Psalm 97

The LORD reigns; let the earth rejoice

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 97. You will read it again later in the plan. Read it now as the answer to Obadiah: the LORD reigns, and pride cannot stand before him.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 97 is a royal psalm, one of a group (Psalms 93, 95 to 99) that begin or center on "The LORD reigns." Coming after Obadiah's judgment on proud Edom, it celebrates God's rule, which terrifies the proud and delights the righteous. The returned community, small and surrounded by hostile neighbors, sang it as a reminder of who is really in charge.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD reigns, let the earth rejoice; let the many coastlands be glad!" (v. 1).
2. "Clouds and thick darkness are all around him; righteousness and justice are the foundation of his throne" (v. 2).
3. "Fire goes before him and burns up his adversaries all around" (v. 3).
4. "The mountains melt like wax before the LORD, before the Lord of all the earth" (v. 5).
5. "The heavens declare his righteousness, and all the peoples see his glory" (v. 6).
6. "All worshipers of images are put to shame, who make their boast in worthless idols" (v. 7).
7. "The LORD loves those who hate evil; he preserves the lives of his saints" (v. 10).
8. "Light is sown for the righteous, and joy for the upright in heart" (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with joy: the reign of God is good news for the whole earth, even the distant coastlands. This is a striking claim. The one who rules is not a distant tyrant but the one on whose throne "righteousness and justice" rest. His reign is moral. It means that the world is not left to chance or to the powerful.

But his presence is awesome. Clouds and thick darkness, fire, lightning, and melting mountains. These are the images of Sinai. They remind the readers that God is holy. The imagery says that no one can approach him without fear unless he provides a way.

The effect on idols is immediate. "All worshipers of images are put to shame." Even the so-called gods bow down before him. This is the same truth you saw in Psalm 115, and Obadiah's warning to Edom. The proud who trust in themselves, in their strongholds, in their false gods will be shamed.

Yet the psalm is not only about terror. Zion hears and is glad, and the daughters of Judah rejoice. The judgments of God are matters for gladness among his people because they mean that wrongs will be set right. And then the psalm gives instruction: "O you who love the LORD, hate evil." Love and hate are linked. Loving the good means rejecting what destroys it. And God "preserves the lives of his saints; he delivers them from the hand of the wicked."

The last two verses contain a beautiful promise: "Light is sown for the righteous, and joy for the upright in heart." The image is of a seed planted in darkness that will rise as light. Those who walk uprightly may seem to sow in sorrow, but God has sown light for them. In the end, the psalm tells us to rejoice in the LORD and give thanks to his holy name.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 19:6: "Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns." Hebrews 1:6 quotes verse 7: "Let all God's angels worship him." John 8:12: "Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life." Romans 12:9: "Abhor what is evil; hold fast to what is good." Matthew 5:14-16 says we are the light of the world. Isaiah 9:2: the people who walked in darkness have seen a great light.

STEP 6

Application

Say aloud, "The LORD reigns," when you feel anxious about the world.

Ask what it means to "hate evil" in a way that is tender toward people.

Receive the promise: “Light is sown for the righteous.” Trust that your faithfulness is not wasted.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you rejoice that he reigns.
- Ask him to shame the idols you are tempted by.
- Thank him for preserving the lives of his saints.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 79

“Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster.”

JOEL 2:13

DAY 552 · WEEK 79

Psalm 98

Sing to the LORD a new song, his salvation revealed

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 98. You will read it again later in the plan. Read it now as the song that follows the judgment: the nations see the salvation of God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 98 is another royal psalm with a new song. Its last verses mirror Psalm 96. Isaac Watts based "Joy to the World" on this psalm, though he reapplied it to the coming of Christ. For the returned exiles, it carried a message: the God who has brought us home will be seen by the whole world.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh sing to the LORD a new song, for he has done marvelous things!" (v. 1).
2. "His right hand and his holy arm have worked salvation for him" (v. 1).
3. "The LORD has made known his salvation; he has revealed his righteousness in the sight of the nations" (v. 2).
4. "He has remembered his steadfast love and faithfulness to the house of Israel" (v. 3).
5. "All the ends of the earth have seen the salvation of our God" (v. 3).
6. "Make a joyful noise to the LORD, all the earth; break forth into joyous song and sing praises!" (v. 4).
7. "Let the rivers clap their hands; let the hills sing for joy together" (vv. 8).
8. "For he comes to judge the earth. He will judge the world with righteousness, and the peoples with equity" (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a new song, because God has done something new. The language of verse 1 is like Isaiah's: his right hand and holy arm have worked salvation. This was the language of the exodus. It is a God who saves, not a God who waits to be saved.

The key is verses 2 and 3. "He has remembered his steadfast love and faithfulness to the house of Israel." God is not forgetful. After the exile, the people had wondered if he had forgotten them. The answer is that he has remembered. And the result is for the whole earth: "All the ends of the earth have seen the salvation of our God." God's saving acts for Israel are meant to be visible to all nations. This is the universal side of God's choice of Israel.

The music rises. A joyful noise, then a whole orchestra: lyre, trumpets, horn. The sea roars and the rivers clap their hands. The hills sing for joy. Creation joins because the Lord is coming. And the reason is judgment: "He will judge the world with righteousness." Again, judgment is a cause for rejoicing. If the judge is righteous, it means that the world will be set right.

In this psalm the coming of the LORD has a double face. For Israel, it is salvation and remembrance of love. For the nations, it is the revelation of his righteousness. For creation, it is the end of groaning. For those who trust him, it is the greatest joy.

When Isaac Watts wrote "Joy to the World," he saw in this psalm the coming of Christ. "Let earth receive her King." It is a faithful reading. The one whose salvation was revealed to the nations came as a baby in Bethlehem, and he will come again.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 2:30-32: Simeon said, "My eyes have seen your salvation that you have prepared in the presence of all peoples, a light for revelation to the Gentiles." Luke 1:54-55 says God has remembered his mercy. Romans 8:19-21: creation waits with eager longing. Acts 17:31: God will judge the world in righteousness by a man whom he has appointed. Revelation 5:9: they sang a new song. Isaiah 52:10: all the ends of the earth shall see the salvation of our God.

STEP 6

Application

Sing a hymn today, such as "Joy to the World," and think of the psalm behind it.

Ask: what "marvelous thing" has God done for you recently? Write it as a new song or a short note.

Pray for the ends of the earth to see his salvation.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Sing to the LORD a new song, in your own words.
- Thank him for the salvation he has revealed.
- Ask him to help you make a joyful noise.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 79

"Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster."

JOEL 2:13

DAY 553 · WEEK 79

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Joel 2:13 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster."

JOEL 2:13

REST

Meditation

This verse is a call to real repentance, and it begins with a contrast. It does not say that outward signs are wrong. It says they are not enough.

"Rend your hearts and not your garments." In the ancient world, tearing your clothes was the standard sign of grief or repentance. But a person could tear a garment and keep a hard heart. God asks for the real thing. Sorrow over sin, turning from it, wanting God. In Psalm 51:17, David says, "The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit."

"Return to the LORD your God." The call is to return, to come home. The picture is of someone who has wandered and needs to return to a loving master. "Your God." Even in rebellion, he is still their God.

“For he is gracious and merciful.” This is the reason to return. It is not that you can earn his favor, but that he is already kind. Gracious means he gives what we do not deserve. Merciful means he does not give what we do deserve.

“Slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love.” His anger is real but slow. His love is abundant, overflowing. This is God’s own description of himself in Exodus 34:6, and it is repeated across the Old Testament, in Nehemiah 9:17, Psalm 145:8, Jonah 4:2, and here.

“And he relents over disaster.” God is willing to turn back from judgment when people turn to him. This does not mean God changes his character, but that he responds to repentance with mercy.

Whenever you feel you have failed, say this verse. It describes a God who is waiting.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the Chronicler’s story of the fall of Judah, with Manasseh’s repentance in Babylon and Josiah’s finding of the Book of the Law. You saw how the book ends with an open door: “Let him go up.” Then you moved to the prophets of the return. In Joel, a swarm of locusts became a picture of the coming day of the LORD, and the prophet’s call was clear: “Return to me with all your heart.” You read the promise of the Spirit poured out on all flesh, and a fountain from the house of the LORD. In Obadiah, you heard God judge proud Edom for standing aloof in the day of Judah’s trouble, and promise that the kingdom shall be the LORD’s. In Psalms 97 and 98, you sang that the LORD reigns and that all the ends of the earth will see his salvation.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Joel says to rend your heart and not your garments. What outward religious habits in your life need an inner reality behind them?

Obadiah condemns standing aloof when a brother suffers. Whom in your life might you be tempted to ignore?

Joel promised the Spirit on all flesh, and Peter said it came at Pentecost. How have you seen the Spirit at work in your life or in your church?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Return to God with all your heart.

Thank him for pouring out his Spirit.

Rest in his love.

DAY 554 · WEEK 80

Psalm 99

The LORD reigns; let the peoples tremble

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 99. You will read it again later in the plan. Read it now as a hymn of the holy God who answers prayer. Notice the refrain “Holy is he.”

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 99 is the last of the “LORD reigns” psalms. It has a threefold refrain: “Holy is he” (vv. 3, 5) and “Holy is the LORD our God” (v. 9). It recalls Moses, Aaron, and Samuel as those who called on God and were answered. Coming right before the prophet Haggai, who will call the people to build the temple, it is a good reminder of the holiness of the place where God meets his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “The LORD reigns; let the peoples tremble! He sits enthroned upon the cherubim; let the earth quake!” (v. 1).
2. “The LORD is great in Zion; he is exalted over all the peoples” (v. 2).
3. “Let them praise your great and awesome name! Holy is he!” (v. 3).
4. “The King in his might loves justice. You have established equity; you have executed justice and righteousness in Jacob” (v. 4).
5. “Exalt the LORD our God; worship at his footstool! Holy is he!” (v. 5).
6. “Moses and Aaron were among his priests, Samuel also was among those who called upon his name. They called to the LORD, and he answered them” (v. 6).
7. “You were a forgiving God to them, but an avenger of their wrongdoings” (v. 8).

8 “Exalt the LORD our God, and worship at his holy mountain; for the LORD our God is holy!” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with God’s majesty. He sits enthroned on the cherubim, which refers to the ark’s mercy seat. He is great in Zion and exalted over all peoples. The proper response is trembling. Holiness is not just moral purity but God’s otherness, his set-apartness, the fact that he is not like us.

The first refrain, “Holy is he,” appears after the call to praise his name. The second appears after the call to worship at his footstool, the temple or ark. The third appears at the end. These three refrains remind us of Isaiah’s vision of the seraphim, who cried “Holy, holy, holy.” This psalm gives the three-fold chant in a different form.

In the center, the psalm says that the strong King loves justice. His holiness is not cold but moral. He establishes equity. A holy God is a just God.

Then comes a surprise. This awesome, holy God answers prayer. “Moses and Aaron… Samuel… called to the LORD, and he answered them.” He spoke to them in the pillar of cloud and gave them his testimonies. The God who sits on the cherubim is the God who speaks to his servants. Holiness and nearness are not opposed.

And then the key line: “You were a forgiving God to them, but an avenger of their wrongdoings.” Moses interceded and was heard, yet there were consequences. God’s forgiveness does not erase reality. This is the pattern of the exile: he forgave, yet the people bore the discipline.

For the returned community, the temple was a holy place to be approached with reverence. The message of Haggai is coming: build the house, because the holy God will dwell there. And for us, the holiness is met by the cross.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 6:3: “Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts.” Revelation 4:8 repeats the threefold holy around the throne. 1 Peter 1:15-16: “You shall be holy, for I am holy.” Hebrews 4:14-16: we have a great high priest who sympathizes with our weaknesses. Hebrews 12:28-29: let us offer acceptable worship with reverence and awe. James 5:16-18: the prayer of a righteous person has great power.

STEP 6

Application

Pause before prayer and remember who you are addressing: the holy God who sits enthroned.

Remember that you can approach him in Christ, and call on him as Moses, Aaron, and Samuel did.

Ask where you have treated God casually, and recover reverence.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tremble before the God who reigns.
- Thank him that he answered those who called on him.
- Worship him at his footstool.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 80

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 555 · WEEK 80

Haggai 1:1-2:23

Rebuild the Temple; the latter glory will be greater

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 38 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Haggai 1:1-2:23. Sixteen years after the return, the temple is still unfinished. Haggai's short messages stir the people to build. Notice the repeated call to "consider your ways."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is 520 BC, the second year of Darius. The foundation of the temple was laid in 536, and then the work stopped. The people built their own houses and left God's house in ruins. Then Haggai appears, with four messages over about four months. His words are brief, direct, and effective. Within weeks the work resumes. The book is a model of how a prophet can move a people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Is it a time for you yourselves to dwell in your paneled houses, while this house lies in ruins?" (1:4).
2. "Now therefore, thus says the LORD of hosts: Consider your ways" (1:5).
3. "You have sown much, and harvested little... and he who earns wages does so to put them into a bag with holes" (1:6).
4. "Go up to the hills and bring wood and build the house, that I may take pleasure in it and that I may be glorified" (1:8).
5. "And the LORD stirred up the spirit of Zerubbabel... and the spirit of Joshua... and the spirit of all the remnant of the people" (1:14).
6. "I am with you, declares the LORD" (1:13).

7. “The latter glory of this house shall be greater than the former, says the LORD of hosts. And in this place I will give peace” (2:9).

8. “On that day… I will take you, O Zerubbabel… and make you like a signet ring, for I have chosen you” (2:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Haggai’s first message is a question: “Is it a time for you to dwell in your paneled houses, while this house lies in ruins?” The people had said, “The time has not yet come.” They had excuses. Hard times, opposition, economic pressure. But Haggai shows that their priorities were backward. They had put their own comfort first, and the result was frustration. “You have sown much and harvested little.” When you put God last, even your best efforts leak away. The phrase “consider your ways” appears twice. It is a call to honest reflection.

The remarkable response is that the leaders and people obey. And God’s answer is brief and wonderful: “I am with you.” He stirs up their spirits, and they begin to work, twenty-three days after Haggai’s first word.

A month later, the older people are discouraged, since this temple looks like nothing compared with Solomon’s. Haggai answers: “Be strong… and work, for I am with you.” Then he says, “The latter glory of this house shall be greater than the former.” This was not because of gold, but because of whose presence would fill it. It points to the day when Jesus, the glory of God in flesh, would walk in that temple.

The third message is about holiness: you cannot make unclean things clean by touching the holy. Ritual and obedience cannot be separated. But from this day forward, God promises to bless.

The last message is to Zerubbabel. God will shake the heavens and earth, overthrow the kingdoms, and make Zerubbabel “like a signet ring.” The signet ring was a symbol of authority. In Jeremiah 22:24, Jehoiachin was rejected as a signet ring. Now the line of David is chosen again. Zerubbabel is a sign that God’s promise to David is alive.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 6:33: “Seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.” Hebrews 12:26-28 quotes Haggai 2:6 about the shaking of heaven and earth and the unshakable kingdom. John 1:14: the Word became flesh and dwelt among us. Matthew 1:12-13: Zerubbabel is in the line of Jesus. 1 Corinthians 3:16-17 says we are God’s temple. Philippians 1:6.

STEP 6

Application

“Consider your ways.” Review how you spend time and money. Is there anything where your own comfort has crowded out God?

Start something you have been postponing for God. Take one small step today.

Take courage from “I am with you” in your work.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to show you where you have put your own house before his.

Ask him to stir your spirit to work for him.

Thank him for the promise that his presence is with you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 80

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 556 · WEEK 80

Zechariah 1:1-3:10

The eight visions begin; the Branch foretold

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Zechariah 1:1-3:10. Zechariah begins with a call to return, and then he sees eight night visions. Today you will read the first four. Read for what each one says about God's care for Jerusalem and his people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Zechariah began prophesying two months after Haggai. He was both a prophet and a priest. His book is full of visions, symbols, and messianic promises, and it is the longest of the Minor Prophets. The first six chapters report eight visions that came in one night. They reassure the discouraged community that God has not forgotten Jerusalem.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Return to me, says the LORD of hosts, and I will return to you" (1:3).
2. "Your fathers, where are they? And the prophets, do they live forever? But my words and my statutes… did they not overtake your fathers?" (1:5-6).
3. "I have returned to Jerusalem with mercy; my house shall be built in it" (1:16).
4. "Jerusalem shall be inhabited as villages without walls, because of the multitude of people and livestock in it" (2:4).
5. "And I will be to her a wall of fire all around, declares the LORD, and I will be the glory in her midst" (2:5).
6. "Sing and rejoice, O daughter of Zion, for behold, I come and I will dwell in your midst" (2:10).
7. "Is not this a brand plucked from the fire?" (3:2).

8 “Behold, I have taken your iniquity away from you, and I will clothe you with pure vestments” (3:4).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book opens with a call that matches the whole Old Testament: “Return to me, and I will return to you.” The previous generation did not listen, but God’s word did what it said. “They repented and said, As the LORD of hosts purposed to deal with us… so has he dealt with us.” Now it is the new generation’s turn.

The visions follow. The first is a man on a red horse among myrtle trees, with angelic patrols. They report that the earth is at rest. But the angel asks, “O LORD of hosts, how long?” The LORD answers with “gracious and comforting words”: “I am exceedingly jealous for Jerusalem.” The second vision, four horns and four craftsmen, shows that the powers that scattered Judah will be dealt with.

The third vision is a man with a measuring line, ready to measure Jerusalem. An angel says that the city will be unwalled, because there will be so many people. And God himself will be “a wall of fire all around” and “the glory in her midst.” This is better than any stone wall. It was wonderful news for those who were proud of Nehemiah’s wall: the true security was the presence of God. “Many nations shall join themselves to the LORD in that day, and shall be my people.”

The fourth vision, in chapter 3, is the center. Joshua the high priest stands before the angel of the LORD, in filthy garments, with Satan at his right hand to accuse him. The LORD rebukes Satan: “Is not this a brand plucked from the fire?” Joshua’s filthy clothes are removed. “Behold, I have taken your iniquity away from you, and I will clothe you with pure vestments.” A clean turban is put on his head. The picture is of justification by grace. Joshua does nothing to earn it. The chapter ends with a promise of “my servant the Branch,” the coming Messiah, and “I will remove the iniquity of this land in a single day.”

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:33-34: “Who shall bring any charge against God’s elect? It is God who justifies.” 2 Corinthians 5:21: for our sake he made him to be sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God. Revelation 7:14: they washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb. Isaiah 61:10: he has clothed me with the garments of salvation. Hebrews 10:10-14: one offering has perfected for all time. Revelation 12:10 describes the accuser of our brothers.

STEP 6

Application

When the accuser reminds you of your failures, answer with chapter 3: “The LORD rebuke you.” Remember you are a brand plucked from the fire.

Thank God for the clean clothes of Christ’s righteousness.

Remember that the best security is God’s presence, not any wall you have built.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Return to God, and thank him for returning to you.

Ask him to be a wall of fire around his people.

Thank him for the Branch.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 80

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 557 · WEEK 80

Zechariah 4:1-6:15

The lampstand; the flying scroll; the Branch crowned

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 35 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Zechariah 4:1-6:15. You will read the remaining four visions: the lampstand and olive trees, the flying scroll, the woman in a basket, and the four chariots. The chapter ends with a crowning ceremony for Joshua. Read 4:6 and 6:12-13 carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The visions continue. The fifth vision shows a golden lampstand fed by two olive trees, and it is meant to encourage Zerubbabel, the governor who is leading the temple's rebuilding. The next three visions deal with sin, and the eighth shows God's judgment on the nations. The section ends with a symbolic act: the crowning of the high priest Joshua, who stands as a picture of the Messiah.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts" (4:6).
2. "Who has despised the day of small things? For these seven shall rejoice, when they see the plumb line in the hand of Zerubbabel" (4:10).
3. "These are the two anointed ones who stand by the Lord of the whole earth" (4:14).
4. "This is the curse that goes out over the face of the whole land" (5:3).
5. "The hands of Zerubbabel have laid the foundation of this house; his hands shall also complete it" (4:9).
6. "Take from the exiles… silver and gold, and make a crown" (6:10-11).
7. "Behold, the man whose name is the Branch: for he shall branch out from his place, and he shall build the temple of the LORD" (6:12).

8 “And he shall bear royal honor, and shall sit and rule on his throne. And there shall be a priest on his throne” (6:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The lampstand vision is among the best known. Zechariah sees a golden lampstand with seven lamps, fed with oil from two olive trees through pipes, with no human hand pouring. The meaning is given in a single sentence: “Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit.” Zerubbabel faces a mountain of difficulty, and he is told that the work will be done by the Spirit of God, not by human strength. The oil is the Spirit, the light is the witness of God’s people, and the supply is limitless. “Who has despised the day of small things?” The small beginning would be finished.

The next three visions are about sin. The flying scroll, thirty feet by fifteen, goes out over the land with a curse on thieves and those who swear falsely. The woman in the basket, “Wickedness,” is carried away to Babylon. God is not just rebuilding a building. He is removing evil from the land. This answers the problem that Ezra and Nehemiah faced: how could the community stay faithful? God would purge it.

The eighth vision of the four chariots goes out to the four winds, and the one going north has “set my Spirit at rest in the north country.” God’s judgment on Babylon is complete.

Then the symbolic act: Zechariah is told to make a crown and set it on the head of Joshua the high priest, and say, “Behold, the man whose name is the Branch.” Joshua is not the Branch himself; he is a sign. The Branch will build the temple, sit and rule on his throne, “and there shall be a priest on his throne.” In Israel, kings and priests were separate. But the Messiah would hold both offices. “The counsel of peace shall be between them both.” This is a clear promise of a priest-king, who is Jesus. And “those who are far off shall come and help to build the temple of the LORD.” The Gentiles will join.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 7:1-3 and Psalm 110:4 describe a priest-king in the order of Melchizedek. Hebrews 4:14-16 names Jesus our great high priest. Luke 1:78 calls Jesus the “sunrise” or “Branch.” Revelation 11:4 uses the two olive trees. Galatians 5:16-25 teaches walking by the Spirit. Acts 1:8: “You will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you.” Ephesians 2:19-22 shows Gentiles built into the temple.

STEP 6

Application

Where are you trying “by might and by power”? Pray, “Not by my strength, but by your Spirit.”

Don’t despise a small beginning. Ask God to finish what he started.

Thank Jesus that he is both king and priest, and has done what Joshua only pictured.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God that it is not by might or power but by his Spirit.
- Ask him not to let you despise the day of small things.
- Ask him to remove wickedness from your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 80

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 558 · WEEK 80

Zechariah 7:1-8:23

True fasting; the LORD returns; nations included

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 37 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Zechariah 7:1-8:23. A delegation asks whether they should keep a fast, and Zechariah answers with a question about justice and mercy. Then come eight promises of restoration. Read the final verses of chapter 8.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Two years after the visions, in 518 BC, a delegation from Bethel asks the priests whether they should continue to mourn and fast in the fifth month, the month the temple was destroyed. Zechariah answers in two parts: first a rebuke about the heart behind religious practice, and then a series of promises. This is the point where the book turns from visions to messages.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “When you fasted and mourned… was it for me that you fasted?” (7:5).
2. “Render true judgments, show kindness and mercy to one another” (7:9).
3. “Do not oppress the widow, the fatherless, the sojourner, or the poor, and let none of you devise evil against another in your heart” (7:10).
4. “They made their hearts diamond-hard lest they should hear the law” (7:12).
5. “I am jealous for Zion with great jealousy” (8:2).
6. “I will return to Zion and dwell in the midst of Jerusalem” (8:3).
7. “Old men and old women shall again sit in the streets of Jerusalem, each with his staff in his hand because of great age. And the streets of the city shall be full of boys and girls playing” (8:4-5).

8 “In those days ten men from the nations of every tongue shall take hold of the robe of a Jew, saying, Let us go with you, for we have heard that God is with you” (8:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The question is about a fast. For seventy years the exiles had fasted in the fifth and seventh months to remember the destruction. Now that the temple is being rebuilt, should they continue? Zechariah first asks a hard question: “Was it for me that you fasted? And when you eat and drink, do you not eat and drink for yourselves?” Their religion had become self-focused. They were going through the motions.

Then he reminds them of the former prophets, who said the same thing: “Render true judgments, show kindness and mercy to one another. Do not oppress the widow, the fatherless, the sojourner, or the poor.” The ancestors would not listen. “They made their hearts diamond-hard.” Justice and mercy were the point. The exile resulted from ignoring them. The people of the return must learn from this.

Then chapter 8 brings ten promises, each beginning, “Thus says the LORD of hosts.” God is jealous for Zion. He will return and dwell in Jerusalem, which will be called the “faithful city.” The picture is of an ordinary, peaceful city: old men and women sitting in the streets, boys and girls playing. It is one of the loveliest images in the prophets. God’s salvation is not only grand but domestic, a place safe for the old and the young.

The people are told: “Let your hands be strong.” And God promises that their fasts will become “joy and gladness and cheerful feasts.” The fast of the fourth, fifth, seventh, and tenth months, all memories of Jerusalem’s fall, will be turned into feasts. Sorrow will be transformed. The chapter ends with a vision of the nations: ten men take hold of a Jew’s robe and say, “Let us go with you, for we have heard that God is with you.” The mission of Israel to the nations is fulfilled in the church.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 58:3-7 describes the fast God desires. Matthew 6:16-18 speaks of fasting before the Father. Matthew 23:23: justice, mercy, and faithfulness are the weightier matters of the law. Micah 6:8: do justice, love kindness, walk humbly. James 1:27: religion that is pure is to visit orphans and widows in their affliction. Luke 5:34-35: when the bridegroom is with us, there is no mourning. Revelation 21:4.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether any spiritual practice in your life has become a ritual done for yourself. Reshape it around love for God and neighbor.

Show “kindness and mercy” to a widow, an orphan, a foreigner, or a poor person this week.

Pray for the day when old men and women sit in the streets and children play, and work for the safety of such a place.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where your religion has been for yourself.
- Ask him to teach you to render true judgments and show mercy.
- Ask him to make you glad in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 80

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 559 · WEEK 80

Zechariah 9:1-11:17

The humble king on a donkey; the shepherd-king

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Zechariah 9:1-11:17. A king comes to Zion on a donkey, and a shepherd is rejected and sold for thirty pieces of silver. These chapters are rich in messianic promises, and the New Testament quotes them often. Read 9:9-10 and 11:12-13 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second half of Zechariah is made of two oracles, chapters 9 to 11 and 12 to 14. They are set in a different style than the visions, and they look to the distant future. They describe the coming of the king, the rejection of the shepherd, and the victory of the LORD. This reading covers the first oracle. The memory verse of this unit comes from chapter 9.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Rejoice greatly, O daughter of Zion! Shout aloud, O daughter of Jerusalem!” (9:9).
2. “Behold, your king is coming to you; righteous and having salvation is he, humble and mounted on a donkey” (9:9).
3. “I will cut off the chariot from Ephraim and the war horse from Jerusalem” (9:10).
4. “And he shall speak peace to the nations; his rule shall be from sea to sea” (9:10).
5. “As for you also, because of the blood of my covenant with you, I will set your prisoners free from the waterless pit” (9:11).
6. “Return to your stronghold, O prisoners of hope” (9:12).
7. “Then I took my staff Grace, and I cut it in two, annulling the covenant that I had made with all the peoples” (11:10).
8. “So they weighed out as my wages thirty pieces of silver” (11:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 9 begins with judgment on the nations around Israel, Syria, Tyre, and Philistia, as God clears the way for his people. Then the focus narrows to a single, striking image: a king arrives in Jerusalem. Everything about him is surprising. He is "righteous and having salvation." He is "humble," or "afflicted." And he rides a donkey, not a war horse. The donkey was a sign of peace and humility. Kings rode horses to war; they rode donkeys when they came in peace (1 Kings 1:33).

His kingdom is likewise surprising. He cuts off the chariot and war horse and the battle bow, and "speaks peace to the nations." His rule reaches from sea to sea. This is a king of peace whose reign is universal, and whose weapon is speech. The Hebrew reading is that his word does it.

Then, "because of the blood of my covenant with you," the prisoners are set free. Notice the phrase "prisoners of hope." Even those who are still in the pit have hope, for a ransom is coming. The covenant is sealed in blood.

Chapters 10 and 11 shift. The people have followed false shepherds. God will care for his flock. But in chapter 11, Zechariah is told to play the part of a shepherd and to care for a doomed flock. He takes two staffs, "Favor" and "Union." The flock rejects him, and he asks for his wages. They weigh out thirty pieces of silver, the price of a slave (Exodus 21:32). The LORD says, "Throw it to the potter," and Zechariah throws the silver into the house of the LORD. It is a bitter irony: the shepherd is valued at the price of a slave.

The final verses describe the worthless shepherd who abandons the flock. This section of Zechariah shows two kings: the humble king who comes in peace and the shepherd who is rejected. They are one person.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 21:1-11 shows Jesus entering Jerusalem on a donkey, quoting Zechariah 9:9. Matthew 26:15 records Judas receiving thirty pieces of silver. Matthew 27:3-10 records the silver being thrown into the temple and used to buy the potter's field. Luke 22:20: "This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood." John 10:11: "I am the good shepherd." Philippians 2:5-8 describes Christ's humility.

STEP 6

Application

Read Matthew 21:1-11 alongside today's reading. Notice how precisely Jesus fulfilled Zechariah.

Think about humility in your leadership or relationships. What does it look like to come in peace, “on a donkey”?

Thank Jesus for being the shepherd who was sold for thirty pieces of silver for you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Rejoice that your King has come, humble and riding on a donkey.

Tell him what you want to say to the shepherd-king.

Thank him for speaking peace.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 80

“Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts.”

ZECHARIAH 4:6

DAY 560 · WEEK 80

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Zechariah 4:6 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts."

ZECHARIAH 4:6

REST

Meditation

This verse was spoken to a governor who was staring at a mountain. Zerubbabel had laid the foundation of the temple, and for years had been unable to finish it. Armies, kings, and officials stood in the way. Into that situation, God spoke a short sentence.

"Not by might." The word means an army or a strong force. Zerubbabel might have thought that the solution was more soldiers or more money. God says no. Human resources are not what will finish the temple.

"Nor by power." The second word means personal strength, ability, or skill. It is not just armies but individuals. Not by his talent, his leadership, or his charisma.

"But by my Spirit." The third phrase is the answer. The work of God is done by the Spirit of God. This is the oil in the lampstand vision, flowing without human hands. The Spirit gives the energy, the wisdom, and the ability to finish.

"Says the LORD of hosts." This is the ground of the promise. The LORD of hosts, the commander of heaven's armies, makes the promise. He can do what armies cannot.

The verse does not say we do nothing. Zerubbabel had to keep building. But the building was to be done in dependence. The result: "He shall bring forward the top stone amid shouts of Grace, grace to it!" When the work is done, the glory goes to God.

Say this verse when you are tempted to rely on your own strength: in a ministry, a marriage, a job, a struggle with sin. It is a reminder that the work belongs to God, and so does the power.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the prophets of the return. In Haggai, you heard a call to "consider your ways" and to build God's house first, and you saw the people's response and God's promise: "I am with you." In Zechariah, you read the eight night visions: the man among the myrtle trees, the wall of fire, Joshua in filthy garments made clean, the lampstand fed by the Spirit, and the crowning of the Branch, a priest on his throne. You heard a rebuke of empty fasting and a promise of old men and children in the streets of a restored Jerusalem. Then you read the first oracle, with the humble king on a donkey, the prisoners of hope, and the shepherd sold for thirty pieces of silver. Earlier in the week, Psalm 99 reminded you of the holiness of the God who answers.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Haggai said, "Consider your ways." What might God show you if you honestly reviewed how you spend your time, energy, and money?

Zechariah showed Joshua cleansed and clothed by grace alone. How does this picture comfort you when you feel unworthy?

The king of Zechariah 9:9 comes humble and on a donkey, yet his rule reaches the ends of the earth. What does that teach you about how God's kingdom advances?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God that it is not by might or power but by his Spirit.

Thank him for the humble King who has come.

Thank him for clothing you in his righteousness.

DAY 561 · WEEK 81

Zechariah 12:1-14:21

The pierced one; the Day of the LORD; living waters

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 36 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Zechariah 12:1-14:21. The LORD defends Jerusalem, a mourning comes over the house of David, a fountain opens for sin, a shepherd is struck, and the LORD becomes king over all the earth. Read 12:10, 13:1, and 14:9 with care.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second oracle, and it is the most apocalyptic section of the book. It uses vivid, symbolic language to describe the end: a siege of Jerusalem, a great mourning, a day of cleansing, and the final victory of the LORD. The New Testament draws heavily on it, especially in the stories of Jesus' death and in Revelation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And I will pour out on the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem a spirit of grace and pleas for mercy" (12:10).
2. "When they look on me, on him whom they have pierced, they shall mourn for him, as one mourns for an only child" (12:10).
3. "On that day there shall be a fountain opened for the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem, to cleanse them from sin and uncleanness" (13:1).
4. "Strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered" (13:7).
5. "And I will put this third into the fire, and refine them as one refines silver" (13:9).
6. "They will call upon my name, and I will answer them. I will say, They are my people; and they will say, The LORD is my God" (13:9).
7. "On that day his feet shall stand on the Mount of Olives" (14:4).

8 “And the LORD will be king over all the earth. On that day the LORD will be one and his name one” (14:9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 12 begins with a statement of God’s power: he stretched out the heavens and founded the earth. Then he promises that Jerusalem will become a cup of staggering and a heavy stone for all the peoples who attack her. God defends his people. But the real victory is spiritual. Verse 10 is among the most important verses in the Old Testament: God will pour out “a spirit of grace and pleas for mercy,” and the people “will look on me, on him whom they have pierced.” God himself speaks, and the pierced one is both God and someone else. The result is great mourning, like the mourning for an only child. It is repentance, a result of grace.

Chapter 13 gives the cleansing. “A fountain opened… to cleanse them from sin and uncleanness.” It is the answer to the problem the whole Old Testament has been dealing with. Sin cannot be washed away by ritual. A fountain must be opened. Idols and false prophets will be removed.

Then comes the haunting verse 7: “Strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered.” The shepherd is “my companion,” says the LORD. God commands the striking of the one who is close to him. This is the suffering shepherd of chapter 11. Through it, one third will be refined as silver and gold, and will say, “The LORD is my God.”

Chapter 14 takes us to the end: the nations fight against Jerusalem, the LORD goes out to fight, his feet stand on the Mount of Olives, which splits in two. Living waters flow out from Jerusalem. Darkness and cold are no more. “And the LORD will be king over all the earth.” Even the pots in Jerusalem will be “holy to the LORD.” The book ends with everything, even the common cooking pots, marked as holy. All of life is consecrated.

STEP 5

Connection

John 19:34-37 says that after the soldiers pierced Jesus’ side, “They will look on him whom they have pierced,” quoting Zechariah 12:10. Revelation 1:7: “Behold, he is coming with the clouds, and every eye will see him, even those who pierced him.” Matthew 26:31 quotes “I will strike the shepherd.” 1 John 1:7: the blood of Jesus cleanses us from all sin. Acts 1:11-12: Jesus ascends from the Mount of Olives. Revelation 22:1: the river of the water of life.

STEP 6

Application

Read John 19:31-37 and look at the pierced one.

Thank God for the fountain opened for sin, and take your own sin there.

Ask God to make “everything holy,” even the ordinary pots of your life: your kitchen, your work, your errands.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to pour out a spirit of grace and pleas for mercy on you.
- Look on the one who was pierced, and tell him what you see.
- Thank him for the fountain that cleanses sin.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 81

“You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins.”

MATTHEW 1:21

DAY 562 · WEEK 81

Malachi 1:1-2:17

“Have I not loved you?”; corrupt priests; broken faith

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Malachi 1:1-2:17. This is the last prophetic book of the Old Testament, written around 430 BC. God opens with love, and then the people argue back at every point. Watch for the repeated pattern: God’s claim, the people’s question, God’s answer.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Malachi’s name means “my messenger.” He writes after the temple is rebuilt and the wall is finished, in the generation of Nehemiah’s second term. The excitement of the return has faded. The sacrifices are routine and halfhearted, the priests are careless, and many have been unfaithful to their wives. The book is set up as a series of six disputes in which God makes a statement, the people ask “How?” or “What?”, and God answers.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “I have loved you, says the LORD. But you say, How have you loved us?” (1:2).
2. “A son honors his father, and a servant his master. If then I am a father, where is my honor?” (1:6).
3. “When you offer blind animals in sacrifice, is that not evil?” (1:8).
4. “Oh that there were one among you who would shut the doors, that you might not kindle fire on my altar in vain!” (1:10).
5. “For from the rising of the sun to its setting my name will be great among the nations” (1:11).
6. “For the lips of a priest should guard knowledge, and people should seek instruction from his mouth” (2:7).

7. “Have we not all one Father? Has not one God created us?” (2:10).
8. “For the man who does not love his wife but divorces her, says the LORD, the God of Israel, covers his garment with violence” (2:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first line gives the key to the whole book: “I have loved you.” It is a statement of fact. But the people respond with doubt: “How have you loved us?” After the return, life was hard. The land was poor, and the nation was a small province under Persia. They wondered whether God’s love was real. God answers by pointing to his choice of Jacob over Esau. He had loved them from the beginning, by electing grace.

The first rebuke is to the priests. Their worship has become an insult. They bring blind, lame, and sick animals for sacrifice, things they would not offer to their governor. “A son honors his father… If then I am a father, where is my honor?” God says he would rather have the temple doors shut than have this halfhearted worship. “I have no pleasure in you.” Worship is not about the ritual but the heart’s honor of God.

In the middle of this rebuke is a remarkable promise: “From the rising of the sun to its setting my name will be great among the nations, and in every place incense will be offered to my name.” The Gentiles will worship. The sacrifices that the priests despise will be replaced by pure offerings from all nations.

Chapter 2 is about the priests’ failure to teach. “The lips of a priest should guard knowledge.” They have turned aside from the way and caused many to stumble. God’s covenant with Levi was one of life and peace, but they have corrupted it.

Then the prophet turns to the people. They have been faithless to one another, marrying foreign wives who worship other gods and divorcing the wives of their youth. The altar of the LORD was covered with tears. “The LORD was witness between you and the wife of your youth.” God hates divorce that comes from faithlessness. The chapter ends with a weary people who have “wearied the LORD with your words.” They say, “Where is the God of justice?” They are asking the question that the whole book is about to answer.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 9:13 quotes “Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated” to speak about God’s electing grace. 1 Peter 2:5 calls us to offer spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God. John 4:21-24 speaks of true worshipers who worship in spirit and truth. Ephesians 5:25: husbands, love your wives as

Christ loved the church. Matthew 19:3-9 speaks of marriage and divorce. Romans 12:1: present your bodies as a living sacrifice. 1 Timothy 3:2 requires teachers to be above reproach.

STEP 6

Application

Ask: am I giving God my best or my leftovers, in time, money, and attention?

Hold onto “I have loved you” when you are tempted to doubt his love.

If you are married, renew your faithfulness. If you teach or lead, guard the knowledge that others depend on.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God where you have doubted his love.
- Confess where you give him what is blind and lame.
- Ask him to teach you to give him your best.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 81

“You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins.”

MATTHEW 1:21

DAY 563 · WEEK 81

Malachi 3:1-4:6

The forerunner; the sun of righteousness, silence before the Word

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Malachi 3:1-4:6. The messenger will prepare the way, the LORD will suddenly come to his temple, and the book ends with the promise of Elijah. This is the last page of the Old Testament in the Christian canon. Read it slowly, as the lights go down.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Malachi's last two chapters answer the people's question, "Where is the God of justice?" God says he is coming. But first a messenger will prepare the way. Then, the LORD himself will come to his temple. The book also addresses the question of tithing, and distinguishes those who serve God from those who do not. It ends with a promise and a warning. After this, there are about four hundred years of silence before the word of God comes again.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, I send my messenger, and he will prepare the way before me" (3:1).
2. "And the Lord whom you seek will suddenly come to his temple; and the messenger of the covenant in whom you delight, behold, he is coming" (3:1).
3. "But who can endure the day of his coming?... For he is like a refiner's fire and like fullers' soap' (3:2).
4. "For I the LORD do not change; therefore you, O children of Jacob, are not consumed" (3:6).
5. "Return to me, and I will return to you" (3:7).
6. "Bring the full tithe into the storehouse, that there may be food in my house" (3:10).

7. “But for you who fear my name, the sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings” (4:2).

8. “Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet before the great and awesome day of the LORD comes. And he will turn the hearts of fathers to their children and the hearts of children to their fathers” (4:5-6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The key announcement is in 3:1. A messenger will prepare the way, and then “the Lord whom you seek will suddenly come to his temple.” The people were asking, “Where is the God of justice?” God says, “I am coming.” But the coming will not be what they expect. They wanted judgment on their enemies. But the LORD says that he will first purify his own people. “Who can endure the day of his coming?” He is like a refiner’s fire and fullers’ soap. He will purify the sons of Levi until they present right offerings.

The next section is a call to return, based on God’s unchanging character: “I the LORD do not change; therefore you, O children of Jacob, are not consumed.” This is one of the great verses of grace. The reason Israel survives is not their faithfulness but God’s. “Return to me, and I will return to you.” The people then ask, “How shall we return?” God says they have robbed him in tithes and offerings. He invites them to bring the full tithe and “put me to the test,” with the promise that he will open the windows of heaven. The test is about trust, not a formula for wealth.

Then there is a division. The people had said that it is vain to serve God. But a group “who feared the LORD spoke with one another,” and the LORD listened and wrote a book of remembrance. “They shall be mine… in the day when I make up my treasured possession.” God keeps a record of the faithful.

The last chapter describes the day coming, burning like an oven, when the proud will be stubble. But for those who fear his name, “the sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings.” That is one of the most beautiful images in the Old Testament. The book ends with a command to remember the law of Moses, and a promise of Elijah to turn hearts before the great day.

Then there is silence. For four hundred years, no prophet speaks. But the promise is hanging in the air: a messenger, a coming Lord, a rising sun.

STEP 5

Connection

Mark 1:2-4 and Matthew 11:10-14 identify John the Baptist as the messenger and as Elijah. Luke 1:17 says John would go before him "in the spirit and power of Elijah." Luke 1:78-79: "The sunrise shall visit us from on high." John 2:13-22: Jesus comes to the temple. Hebrews 13:8: "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever." Revelation 20:12 mentions the books that are opened. Matthew 3:1-3 introduces John the Baptist.

STEP 6

Application

Read Mark 1:1-8 immediately after this passage. Notice where the Old Testament ends and the Gospel begins.

Give to God first, and trust him to provide.

Pray for the "turning of hearts" between fathers and children in your family.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he does not change and so you are not consumed.

Ask him to refine you and return you to him.

Ask him to prepare you for the coming of the Lord.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 81

"You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins."

MATTHEW 1:21

DAY 564 · WEEK 81

Review and Reflection

Unit 14 review, The Return & the Chronicles Perspective

Year 1 · Unit 14 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "Behold, your king is coming to you; righteous and having salvation is he, humble and mounted on a donkey."
>
> ZECHARIAH 9:9

REST

Meditation

This verse stands near the end of the Old Testament like a lamp in a dark room. After centuries of kings who failed, a king is promised who will not. Every phrase counts.

"Behold." The word calls us to stop and look. Something is about to be shown.

"Your king is coming to you." The king is not a distant ruler. He comes to his people. After the return, the Jews had no king of their own. They were governed by Persians. The promise is that their king would come in person. The one who comes belongs to them and comes toward them.

"Righteous." Every earthly king in the Old Testament had flaws. Even David failed. This king is righteous, fully and perfectly. He does what is right.

"And having salvation is he." The phrase can mean he is saved, or he brings salvation. Both are true. He is delivered by God and he delivers others. His mission is to save.

"Humble." The Hebrew word means afflicted or lowly. This king comes not with power but in weakness. He enters Jerusalem not in the pride of a conqueror but in the humility of a servant.

"Mounted on a donkey." The picture is of peace. The next verse says he will cut off the war horse and speak peace to the nations. The kingdom he brings does not come by the sword.

When Jesus rode into Jerusalem on a donkey, the crowds shouted, “Hosanna!” They were seeing this verse come true. He was the king who came to them, righteous, saving, and humble, and he would give his life.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

Unit 14 closed the Old Testament with a partial return. You saw God keep his word through Cyrus, bringing a remnant home to rebuild the altar, the temple, and the wall. In Ezra and Nehemiah, you read of prayer and obstruction, of the word of God read aloud, and of joy and tears mingled, followed by the sad return to old sins. In Esther, you saw God’s hidden hand preserve his people in a foreign land. In Chronicles, the whole story was retold for the returned community, from Adam to Cyrus, with David’s covenant at its center and the repeated call to seek the LORD. Then the prophets of the return spoke. Joel called for hearts to be torn and promised the Spirit. Obadiah warned against pride and standing aloof. Haggai stirred the builders. Zechariah showed a clean Joshua, a humble king on a donkey, a pierced one, an opened fountain, and a Lord who will be king over all the earth. Malachi ended with love, a sharp rebuke, and a promise: a messenger, a Lord who will come suddenly to his temple, a sun of righteousness, and Elijah before the day. The Old Testament closes with its promises unfulfilled. The people are home, but the glory is not yet fully back, and the king has not come. Four hundred years of silence will follow, but the promise stands. Everything you have read from Genesis to Malachi has been preparing for the Gospel.

REFLECT

Review Questions

Why does the post-exilic community’s joy at the Temple’s rebuilding turn to weeping?

Think about Ezra 3:10-13 and Haggai 2:3. What did the old men remember, and what does the contrast say about the return being partial?

What does Chronicles add to our understanding of the monarchy?

Consider the Chronicler’s focus on David, the temple, and the repeated call to “seek the LORD.” How does it differ from Kings, and what does it say to a people with no king?

How does Malachi set up the 400 years of silence before Christ?

Look at Malachi 3:1, 4:2, and 4:5-6. What promises are left hanging, and who do the Gospels say fulfills them?

What do the visions in Zechariah reveal about the coming Messiah?

Think of the Branch, the priest on his throne, the humble king on a donkey, the shepherd sold for thirty pieces of silver, and the pierced one. How do these pictures fit together?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for carrying his people through exile and return.

Thank him for the promises that point to Christ.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 15 · DAYS 565-602

The New Covenant Inaugurated: Matthew

Matthew 1-28

Jesus as the new Moses, new David, and new Israel. The Kingdom arrives in a person.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"You are the Christ, the Son of the living God."

MATTHEW 16:16

Psalm 1 beside the Sermon on the Mount. Psalms 146 and 147 beside the healings. Psalms 2 and 110 beside the Transfiguration. Psalm 118 in Holy Week.

UNIT 15

In this unit

WEEK 81

565	Matthew 1:1-2:23	*Reading*
566	Matthew 3:1-4:25	*Reading*
567	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 82

568	Matthew 5:1-20	*Reading*
569	Matthew 5:21-48	*Reading*
570	Matthew 6:1-34	*Reading*
571	Matthew 6:5-15; Luke 11:1-13	*Doctrine*
572	Matthew 7:1-29	*Reading*
573	Psalm 1	*Psalm*
574	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 83

575	Psalm 146	*Psalm*
576	Psalm 147:1-11	*Psalm*
577	Matthew 8:1-9:38	*Reading*
578	Matthew 10:1-11:30	*Reading*
579	Matthew 12:1-13:23	*Reading*
580	Psalm 78:1-16	*Psalm*
581	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 84

582	Psalm 25	*Psalm*
583	Matthew 13:24-14:36	*Reading*
584	Matthew 15:1-16:28	*Reading*
585	Matthew 17:1-18:35	*Reading*
586	Psalm 2	*Psalm*

587	Psalm 110	*Psalm*
588	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 85

589	Matthew 19:1-20:34	*Reading*
590	Matthew 21:1-22:14	*Reading*
591	Matthew 22:15-23:39	*Reading*
592	Matthew 24:1-25:46	*Reading*
593	Psalm 118	*Psalm*
594	Matthew 26:1-46	*Reading*
595	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 86

596	Matthew 26:47-27:31	*Reading*
597	Matthew 27:32-66	*Reading*
598	Matthew 28:1-20	*Reading*
599	Deuteronomy 6:4; Matthew 28:18-20; 2 Corinthians 13:14	*Doctrine*
600	Matthew 28:18-20; Romans 6:1-4; Acts 2:38-41; Colossians 2:11-12	*Doctrine*
601	Review and Reflection	*Review*
602	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 565 · WEEK 81

Matthew 1:1-2:23

The genealogy; the birth; the Magi, new Israel begins

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 1:1-2:23. The New Testament opens with a list of names. Read it as the final page of the Old Testament's story, then follow the child from Bethlehem to Egypt and back to Nazareth.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After four hundred years of prophetic silence, the first words of the New Testament are "The book of the genealogy of Jesus Christ, the son of David, the son of Abraham." Matthew was a tax collector who became one of the Twelve, and he writes mainly for Jewish readers. His aim is to show that Jesus is the one the whole Old Testament was waiting for. He quotes or echoes Israel's Scriptures more than any other Gospel writer, and he says again and again that something happened "to fulfill what the Lord had spoken by the prophet."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The book of the genealogy of Jesus Christ, the son of David, the son of Abraham" (1:1).
2. "And Judah the father of Perez and Zerah by Tamar" (1:3).
3. "And Salmon the father of Boaz by Rahab, and Boaz the father of Obed by Ruth" (1:5).
4. "You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins" (1:21).
5. "And they shall call his name Immanuel (which means, God with us)" (1:23).
6. "Where is he who has been born king of the Jews? For we saw his star when it rose and have come to worship him" (2:2).
7. "And you, O Bethlehem, in the land of Judah, are by no means least among the rulers of Judah" (2:6).

8 “Out of Egypt I called my son” (2:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Matthew’s genealogy is a short history of the covenants. It begins with Abraham, to whom God promised a blessing for all nations, and moves to David, to whom God promised a throne that would never end. It ends at the exile and then with Jesus. Matthew arranges it in three sets of fourteen, a pattern that is itself a quiet claim: David’s line, broken in Babylon, has now arrived at its Messiah.

Notice who is in the list. Four women are named, which was unusual in a genealogy: Tamar, Rahab, Ruth, and the wife of Uriah. Several were outsiders and some were involved in scandal. Matthew is telling us at the outset that the Messiah comes through the real, messy story of sinners and foreigners, and that grace has been at work in his family tree all along.

The birth story is told from Joseph’s side. He is a righteous man who plans to quietly end the engagement, and God steps in. The name Jesus means “the LORD saves,” and the angel gives its meaning: he will save his people from their sins. That is a bigger rescue than overthrowing Rome. Then Isaiah’s promise is quoted: Immanuel, God with us. The book will end with Jesus saying, “I am with you always,” so the whole Gospel is framed by that promise.

In chapter 2, foreign astrologers come to worship the new king while the king in Jerusalem is troubled and the religious experts know where he will be born but do not go. Herod tries to kill the child. Jesus is taken to Egypt and brought back, and Matthew quotes Hosea: “Out of Egypt I called my son.” Hosea was speaking about Israel in the exodus. Matthew sees Jesus as the true Israel, who relives the nation’s story and does what it failed to do.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 12:3 promised that all families of the earth would be blessed through Abraham, and the Magi are the first fruits of that. 2 Samuel 7:12-13 is the promise of David’s throne. Isaiah 7:14 is the Immanuel passage you read in Unit 11. Micah 5:2 names Bethlehem. Romans 5:20 says that where sin increased, grace abounded all the more. Galatians 4:4-5 says that in the fullness of time God sent his Son to redeem those under the law.

STEP 6

Application

Read the genealogy aloud, slowly, and thank God for the sinners and outsiders in it. Then thank him that your own story is not too messy for his grace.

Ask what it would mean to treat Jesus as “God with us” in your ordinary Tuesday.

Notice the difference between the Magi and the scribes: one group traveled far to worship, and the other knew the Bible and stayed home. Which are you more like this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for keeping every promise to Abraham and David in Jesus.
- Tell him what it means that Jesus came to save his people from their sins.
- Ask him to teach you to worship as the Magi did.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 81

“You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins.”

MATTHEW 1:21

DAY 566 · WEEK 81

Matthew 3:1-4:25

John the Baptist; the baptism; the temptation

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 49 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 3:1-4:25. John prepares the way, Jesus is baptized, and the Father speaks. Then Jesus is led into the wilderness, where he is tempted, and he begins to call disciples. Watch how Jesus answers the devil.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is about thirty years old when his public ministry begins. John the Baptist has been preaching in the Judean wilderness near the Jordan, calling Israel to repent in preparation for the king. Matthew presents what happens at the Jordan and in the wilderness as the start of a new exodus: Israel passed through the sea and was tested for forty years, and now Israel's true Son passes through the water and is tested for forty days.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand" (3:2).
2. "Bear fruit in keeping with repentance" (3:8).
3. "I baptize you with water for repentance, but he who is coming after me is mightier than I" (3:11).
4. "Let it be so now, for thus it is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness" (3:15).
5. "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased" (3:17).
6. "Then Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil" (4:1).
7. "It is written, Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God" (4:4).

8 “Follow me, and I will make you fishers of men” (4:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John’s message is simple: the king is coming, so turn around. The crowds come to be baptized, confessing their sins, but when religious leaders come, John warns them not to rest on being Abraham’s descendants. Fruit, not family, shows repentance.

Then Jesus comes to be baptized, which seems backward. John hesitates, because Jesus has no sins to confess. Jesus says it is fitting “to fulfill all righteousness.” He stands with sinners and takes his place among them, which anticipates the cross. The heavens open, the Spirit descends, and the Father speaks the words that combine Psalm 2 (a royal son) and Isaiah 42 (the servant in whom God delights). Jesus is both the king and the suffering servant.

Immediately the Spirit drives him into the wilderness. Israel failed its testing at hunger, at testing God, and at idolatry. Jesus faces the same three. When he is hungry, he answers with Deuteronomy 8: people live by every word from God’s mouth. When the devil quotes Scripture and tells him to throw himself down, Jesus answers from Deuteronomy 6: do not put the LORD your God to the test. When offered all the kingdoms of the world without a cross, he answers from Deuteronomy 6 again: worship the Lord alone. Every answer is a verse from the book Israel had been given in the wilderness. Jesus succeeds where Israel failed, and he does it by knowing and trusting the word.

Chapter 4 ends with the first disciples leaving their nets and the crowds beginning to gather. The kingdom he announces comes with healing and teaching.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 2:7 and Isaiah 42:1 stand behind the Father’s words at the baptism. Deuteronomy 8:3, 6:16, and 6:13 are the three verses Jesus quotes. Hebrews 4:15 says we have a high priest who in every respect has been tempted as we are, yet without sin. 1 Corinthians 10:1-13 compares Israel’s wilderness failures to our own testing. Ephesians 6:17 calls the word of God the sword of the Spirit.

STEP 6

Application

When you are tempted, answer with a specific verse you know. Choose one this week and memorize it for that purpose.

Notice that Jesus was tempted right after he was told he was God’s beloved Son. Being loved by the Father does not mean being spared trials.

Respond to Jesus' call to follow. What is one "net" you may need to put down?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for standing with sinners at the Jordan and standing firm in the wilderness.

Ask him to teach you to live by every word from God's mouth.

Tell him what you are tempted by.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 81

"You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins."

MATTHEW 1:21

DAY 567 · WEEK 81

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Matthew 1:21 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins."

MATTHEW 1:21

REST

Meditation

An angel speaks these words to Joseph in a dream, and they contain the whole mission of Jesus in one sentence.

"You shall call his name Jesus." The name is the Greek form of Joshua, which means "the LORD saves." Names in Scripture often carry meaning, and this one is a sermon. Joseph does not choose it. God does. Joseph is asked to take the child as his own and to give him the name.

"For he will save." The verb is about rescue. Matthew does not say he will try, or offer help, or point the way. He will save. The child in the manger is the rescuer.

"His people." The people are those who belong to him. In the Old Testament, that meant Israel. By the end of this Gospel, it includes people from every nation who follow him. Matthew begins with a family tree that includes outsiders for a reason.

“From their sins.” This is the surprising part. A first-century Jew would have expected rescue from Rome. Matthew says the deepest problem is not political but moral, and the solution is a Savior who deals with sin itself. He does this at the cross, where he bears it.

Say this verse whenever you wonder what Jesus came to do. He came to save his people from their sins, and that includes you if you belong to him.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the Old Testament and began the New. You read Zechariah’s vision of a fountain, a pierced one, and the LORD as king over all the earth. In Malachi you heard God’s love, his rebuke, and the promise of a messenger and a sun of righteousness. You reviewed the whole Unit 14 story of the return. Then, on the first two days of Matthew, you saw the genealogy that gathers up the covenants of Abraham and David, the virgin birth and the name Jesus, the Magi who came to worship, and the escape to Egypt. You watched John prepare the way, Jesus baptized with the Father’s voice from heaven, and Jesus overcome the devil’s temptations by quoting Deuteronomy. The silence between the Testaments is over, and the promises are arriving in a person.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Matthew’s genealogy includes Tamar, Rahab, and Ruth. What does that tell you about the kind of people Jesus came for?

The name Jesus means “the LORD saves.” In what area of your life do you most need to remember that he saves?

Jesus answered each temptation with Scripture. Which Scripture is helping you stand right now, and which one might you memorize next?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for coming to save his people from their sins.

Thank God for the long story that led to him.

Rest in his salvation.

DAY 568 · WEEK 82

Matthew 5:1-20

The Beatitudes; salt and light; the law fulfilled

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 5:1-20. This is the opening of the Sermon on the Mount. Read the Beatitudes slowly, one at a time, and notice how each begins with a blessing and ends with a promise.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus goes up on a mountain, sits down as a teacher would, and speaks to his disciples while crowds listen. Matthew has just shown Jesus as the new Israel. Now he shows him as the new Moses, giving a teaching from a mountain, as Moses did at Sinai. The Sermon is not a list of requirements for earning God's favor. It is a portrait of life in the kingdom that has arrived, addressed to people who already belong to him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven" (5:3).
2. "Blessed are those who mourn, for they shall be comforted" (5:4).
3. "Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the earth" (5:5).
4. "Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they shall be satisfied" (5:6).
5. "Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God" (5:8).
6. "Blessed are those who are persecuted for righteousness" sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven' (5:10).
7. "You are the light of the world. A city set on a hill cannot be hidden" (5:14).

8 “Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them” (5:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Beatitudes turn the world’s idea of success upside down. The people called blessed are the poor in spirit, the mourners, the meek, and the persecuted. These are not the ones the world admires. Yet each is promised something: the kingdom, comfort, the earth, satisfaction, mercy, the sight of God. The blessing is not a reward for being good enough. These are people who know their need, and the kingdom belongs to those who know they cannot get there on their own.

The first and last Beatitudes promise the same thing, the kingdom of heaven, which frames the whole list. The ones between them describe what kingdom people are like: they grieve over sin, they are gentle, they long for what is right, they show mercy, they have undivided hearts, and they make peace. And as the verses go on, Jesus tells them to expect opposition.

He then calls his followers salt and light. Salt preserves and flavors, and light shows the way. Both are useless if hidden or diluted. The point is not to draw attention to ourselves but that people “may see your good works and give glory to your Father in heaven.”

Verses 17 to 20 are the hinge. Jesus did not come to throw away the Old Testament. He came to fulfill it, which means to bring it to its intended goal. The law and prophets pointed to him, and he completes what they began. And when he says that our righteousness must exceed that of the scribes and Pharisees, he sets up an impossible standard that only he can meet and then give to us. The rest of the Sermon shows how deep that righteousness goes.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 19 and 20 describe the giving of the law from a mountain. Isaiah 61:1-3 promises good news for the poor and comfort for those who mourn. Psalm 37:11 says the meek shall inherit the land. Psalm 24:3-4 asks who may ascend the hill of the LORD, and the answer is the clean of hands and pure of heart. Philippians 2:15 says believers shine as lights in the world. Romans 10:4 says Christ is the end, or goal, of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes.

STEP 6

Application

Pick one Beatitude and ask where it describes you or challenges you. Pray about that specific one today.

Ask what “poor in spirit” would look like in your work, your marriage, or your church. How would you act if you knew you needed God for everything?

Do one visible good work today that points toward the Father, not toward you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to make you poor in spirit, aware of your need.
- Tell him what you hunger and thirst for.
- Ask him to let your light shine so that others give glory to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 82

“In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven.”

MATTHEW 5:16

DAY 569 · WEEK 82

Matthew 5:21-48

The law's true demand, heart-level obedience

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 5:21-48. Jesus takes six commands from the law and goes beneath the surface of each one. Notice the repeated phrase "You have heard that it was said... But I say to you."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Having said he came to fulfill the law, Jesus now shows what that means. The religious teachers of the day had narrowed the law to outward behavior, often with loopholes. Jesus takes six examples, murder, adultery, divorce, oaths, retaliation, and love for enemies, and shows that God's law was always aimed at the heart. He does not set aside Moses. He reveals what Moses meant.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You have heard that it was said to those of old, You shall not murder... But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother will be liable to judgment" (5:21-22).
2. "So if you are offering your gift at the altar and there remember that your brother has something against you, leave your gift there before the altar and go. First be reconciled to your brother" (5:23-24).
3. "Everyone who looks at a woman with lustful intent has already committed adultery with her in his heart" (5:28).
4. "If your right eye causes you to sin, tear it out and throw it away" (5:29).
5. "Let what you say be simply Yes or No" (5:37).
6. "But I say to you, Do not resist the one who is evil" (5:39).

7. “Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you” (5:44).
8. “You therefore must be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect” (5:48).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Each of the six examples follows the same pattern. Jesus quotes the commandment, and then he goes to the root. Murder starts in anger and contempt. Adultery starts in lust. Faithfulness in speech should not need oaths. Love should not stop at those who love us back. He is not adding new rules but exposing what the old ones always demanded.

The effect is meant to be unsettling. A person who thinks he has kept the law by avoiding murder finds that he has been angry. A person who has avoided adultery finds that he has looked with desire. No one can say, “I have kept all these.” Jesus has made the standard so high that everyone has to see that righteousness cannot be earned. That is why the Beatitudes began with the poor in spirit.

His strong language about tearing out an eye is not a command to self-harm but a way of saying that sin must be dealt with seriously, whatever it costs. And his teaching on retaliation points to a different way of living. Instead of getting even, his people absorb insult and give generously, trusting the Father to be their defender.

The last command is the most demanding: “Be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect.” The context is love for enemies. God sends rain and sun on the just and unjust alike, and his children are meant to look like him. “Perfect” here means whole, complete, not partial. Only one person has ever lived this out. That is why the Sermon drives us to Christ, who lived it for us and then gives his Spirit to begin forming it in us.

STEP 5

Connection

1 John 3:15 says everyone who hates his brother is a murderer. James 1:14-15 traces sin from desire to death. Proverbs 4:23 says to guard your heart. Romans 12:17-21 echoes Jesus on overcoming evil with good. Luke 23:34 shows Jesus praying for his enemies on the cross. Romans 5:8 says that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us. Galatians 3:10-14 says Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law.

STEP 6

Application

Think of someone you are angry with. Ask what first step toward reconciliation God might want from you today.

Be honest about one area where outward obedience hides an inward struggle. Confess it to God, who already knows.

Pray for an enemy or a difficult person by name this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess the anger, desire, or love that stops short in you.

Thank Jesus for fulfilling the law you cannot.

Ask him to change your heart from the inside.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 82

"In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven."

MATTHEW 5:16

DAY 570 · WEEK 82

Matthew 6:1-34

Prayer, fasting, treasure, anxiety, the Father in heaven

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 34 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 6:1-34. Jesus turns from the law to the practices of the religious life: giving, praying, and fasting. Then he deals with money and anxiety. Notice how often he says “your Father who sees in secret.”

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second part of the Sermon is about the heart behind devotion. In first-century Judaism, giving, prayer, and fasting were the three marks of a pious person, and it was tempting to do them for the applause of others. Jesus asks his followers to do them for an audience of one. Then he addresses the two great rivals to trust in the Father: money and worry.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Beware of practicing your righteousness before other people in order to be seen by them” (6:1).
2. “But when you give to the needy, do not let your left hand know what your right hand is doing” (6:3).
3. “Go into your room and shut the door and pray to your Father who is in secret” (6:6).
4. “Your Father knows what you need before you ask him” (6:8).
5. “Pray then like this: Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name” (6:9).
6. “Do not lay up for yourselves treasures on earth… but lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven” (6:19-20).
7. “No one can serve two masters… You cannot serve God and money” (6:24).

8 “But seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you” (6:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus warns about acting religious for show. The people who give, pray, and fast to be seen get exactly what they wanted, the praise of people, and nothing more. Those who do these things in secret have a Father who sees and will reward. The difference is who we are performing for.

At the center is the model prayer. It starts with “Our Father,” not “My Father,” and with God’s name, his kingdom, and his will before our needs. Then it asks for daily bread, forgiveness, and protection from temptation. Notice that the prayer is short and simple. Jesus says that pagans heap up empty phrases, thinking they will be heard for their many words, but the Father already knows what we need. Prayer is not about informing or persuading God. It is about coming to him as children.

The teaching on forgiveness (6:14-15) is sobering. The forgiven are expected to forgive. This is not a transaction, but it describes the character of those who have truly received mercy.

Then Jesus turns to treasure and worry. We cannot serve both God and money. He points to the birds, which do not farm and yet are fed, and to the lilies, which do not spin and yet are clothed. “Are you not of more value than they?” Anxiety assumes that we are on our own. Jesus says we have a Father. The cure for worry is not simply to try harder to stop, but to seek first the kingdom and trust that the Father will provide. Take one day at a time: “Sufficient for the day is its own trouble.”

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 58:6-9 describes the fasting God desires. Luke 11:1-4 gives Luke’s version of the Lord’s Prayer. 1 Timothy 6:6-10 warns about the love of money. Philippians 4:6-7 says not to be anxious, but to pray with thanksgiving and receive God’s peace. 1 Peter 5:7 says to cast all your anxieties on him because he cares for you. Psalm 55:22 says to cast your burden on the LORD. Romans 8:32 says that the God who gave his Son will also give us all things.

STEP 6

Application

Do one act of giving or service this week that no one will know about except God.

Name your biggest worry. Hand it to the Father in prayer, using Jesus’ reasoning: “You are of more value than the birds.”

Pray the Lord's Prayer slowly today, pausing on each phrase.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pray the Lord's Prayer slowly, pausing at each line to add your own words.
- Ask him for today's bread and to forgive your sins.
- Ask him to loosen your anxiety and teach you to trust your Father.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 82

"In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven."

MATTHEW 5:16

DAY 571 · WEEK 82

Matthew 6:5-15; Luke 11:1-13

Prayer

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 6:5-15, then Luke 11:1-13. Today is a doctrinal pause on prayer, so you are reading two accounts together. Notice that in Luke the disciples ask Jesus to teach them to pray, and he gives the prayer and then a parable and a promise.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday you read the Lord's Prayer within the Sermon on the Mount. Luke records a different occasion. Jesus had been praying, and when he finished, one of his disciples said, "Lord, teach us to pray." Jesus gave them the pattern again in a slightly shorter form, and then taught about asking, seeking, and knocking. Together the two passages give a foundation for what the Bible teaches about prayer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When you pray, you must not be like the hypocrites" (Matthew 6:5).
2. "Your Father knows what you need before you ask him" (Matthew 6:8).
3. "Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name" (Matthew 6:9).
4. "Forgive us our debts, as we also have forgiven our debtors" (Matthew 6:12).
5. "Lord, teach us to pray, as John taught his disciples" (Luke 11:1).
6. "Father, hallowed be your name. Your kingdom come" (Luke 11:2).
7. "Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you" (Luke 11:9).
8. "How much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him!" (Luke 11:13).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Prayer is the means by which believers speak to God as their Father through Jesus Christ, in the power of the Holy Spirit. It includes praise, thanksgiving, confession, and petition. God does not need to be informed of what we need, and prayer does not change his purposes. Rather, he has chosen to bring about his purposes through the prayers of his people. We pray in Jesus' name, which means that we come through his work and on his authority, not our own merit. Prayer is not a technique for getting what we want but a relationship in which we are conformed to the Father's will.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus' teaching on prayer begins with how not to pray. Hypocrites pray to be seen, and pagans pile up words. Neither is how a child talks to a father. Jesus says to go into your room, close the door, and pray to your Father in secret. Real prayer is a personal conversation, not a performance.

The prayer itself begins with "Our Father." This word alone changes everything. We are not approaching a distant ruler or a force. Through Christ we are children addressing a Father who loves us. Then come three petitions about God: his name be treated as holy, his kingdom come, his will be done. We start by wanting what he wants. Only then do we turn to ourselves: daily bread, forgiveness, and deliverance from the evil one. The order teaches us what to put first.

Luke adds a story. A man knocks at his friend's door at midnight to borrow bread, and the friend gets up not out of friendship but because of the man's persistence. Jesus' point is a contrast: if even a reluctant neighbor responds, how much more will the Father? So we ask, seek, and knock. The verbs are in the present tense, suggesting continual asking.

And then the surprising conclusion. A father does not give a snake to a child who asks for a fish. If earthly parents, "who are evil," give good gifts, how much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him? The greatest answer to prayer is not an object but God himself, present in us by his Spirit. This does not mean that every request will be granted as we ask, but that the Father will always give what is good.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:15-16 says we have received the Spirit of adoption by whom we cry "Abba, Father." Romans 8:26-27 says the Spirit helps us in our weakness when we do not know what to pray. John 14:13-14 teaches prayer in Jesus' name. Hebrews 4:16 invites us to approach the throne

of grace with confidence. 1 John 5:14 says that if we ask anything according to his will, he hears us. Philippians 4:6 says to make requests known to God with thanksgiving. James 4:2-3 warns about asking with wrong motives.

STEP 6

Application

Set aside a regular time and place to pray, even for ten minutes. Use the Lord's Prayer as an outline: praise, God's kingdom, daily needs, forgiveness, protection.

Keep a short list of requests you are bringing to the Father, and note when he answers.

Ask for the Holy Spirit, as Jesus invites, and ask specifically for help in a weakness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that through Jesus you can call him Father.
- Pray each petition of the Lord's Prayer in your own words.
- Ask him to teach you to pray with persistence.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 82

"In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven."

MATTHEW 5:16

DAY 572 · WEEK 82

Matthew 7:1-29

Judging, asking, the narrow way, the two foundations

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 29 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 7:1-29. Jesus ends the Sermon with warnings about judging, a call to ask the Father, the narrow gate, false prophets, and the two builders. Pay attention to the last verses of the chapter.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The final chapter of the Sermon moves from describing the kingdom life to urging a response. Jesus warns his hearers against false religion and calls for decision. The Sermon ends not with a list of rules but with a choice between two roads, two trees, and two foundations. Everyone who hears must act.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Judge not, that you be not judged” (7:1).
2. “First take the log out of your own eye, and then you will see clearly to take the speck out of your brother’s eye” (7:5).
3. “Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you” (7:7).
4. “So whatever you wish that others would do to you, do also to them, for this is the Law and the Prophets” (7:12).
5. “Enter by the narrow gate. For the gate is wide and the way is easy that leads to destruction” (7:13).
6. “You will recognize them by their fruits” (7:16).

7. “Not everyone who says to me, Lord, Lord, will enter the kingdom of heaven, but the one who does the will of my Father” (7:21).

8. “And when Jesus finished these sayings, the crowds were astonished at his teaching, for he was teaching them as one who had authority” (7:28-29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus does not forbid all discernment, since he later tells us to recognize false prophets by their fruit. He forbids a harsh, hypocritical spirit that picks at others’ faults while ignoring our own. The image of a log in the eye is humorous and deliberate. First deal with yourself, and then you can help your brother with clear sight.

The call to ask, seek, and knock comes back again, because the Christian life depends on a Father who gives. And the Golden Rule sums up the whole ethic: treat others as you want to be treated. It is the Law and the Prophets in a sentence.

Then comes a choice. There are two gates, one wide and easy, and one narrow and hard. There are two kinds of trees and two kinds of fruit. The popular road is not the safe one. Jesus’ warning that some who say “Lord, Lord” will be turned away is one of the most sobering in the Bible. These people did religious things, prophesied, cast out demons, and did mighty works in his name. But he says, “I never knew you.” The test is not activity but a relationship with Christ shown in obedience.

The closing story is of two builders. Both heard the same words. One built on rock and one on sand. The storm tested both, and only the house on the rock stood. The difference was not hearing but doing. The crowds were astonished, because Jesus taught with his own authority, not by quoting other rabbis. The one who has given the Sermon is also the one who will judge. The way to be safe is to build on him.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 2:1 warns that when you judge another, you condemn yourself. James 1:22-25 says to be doers of the word and not hearers only. Luke 6:46-49 gives the parallel to the two builders. John 10:9: “I am the door; if anyone enters by me, he will be saved.” John 14:6: “I am the way, and the truth, and the life.” Ephesians 2:20 says Christ Jesus himself is the cornerstone. 1 Corinthians 3:11: no one can lay a foundation other than Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you are looking at the speck in someone else while ignoring your own log. Confess it.

Pick one thing from the Sermon on the Mount that you have heard but not done. Do it this week.

Ask yourself honestly: are you building your life on Christ, or on something that will not survive a storm?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you judge others while ignoring your own sin.
- Ask him to help you enter by the narrow way.
- Ask him to build your life on the rock of his words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 82

"In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven."

MATTHEW 5:16

DAY 573 · WEEK 82

Psalm 1

Blessed is the man, the two ways behind the Sermon

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 1. This short psalm is the doorway to the whole Psalter, and its two paths sit right behind the Sermon on the Mount. Read it aloud and compare the tree with the chaff.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 1 has no title and no author, and it opens the book of Psalms by setting two ways of life side by side. After reading Jesus' Sermon, with its two gates, two trees, and two foundations, you can hear that Jesus was drawing on this psalm. It is a wisdom poem that asks the reader to choose.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed is the man who walks not in the counsel of the wicked" (v. 1).
2. "Nor stands in the way of sinners, nor sits in the seat of scoffers" (v. 1).
3. "But his delight is in the law of the LORD, and on his law he meditates day and night" (v. 2).
4. "He is like a tree planted by streams of water that yields its fruit in its season" (v. 3).
5. "And its leaf does not wither" (v. 3).
6. "In all that he does, he prospers" (v. 3).
7. "The wicked are not so, but are like chaff that the wind drives away" (v. 4).
8. "For the LORD knows the way of the righteous, but the way of the wicked will perish" (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a progression: walking, standing, sitting. The person who drifts from listening to the wicked, to lingering with sinners, to settling in with scoffers is on a slide. The blessed person turns away from this and finds his delight in God's law, his instruction, and thinks about it all the time.

The picture of the tree is lovely. It is planted, not wild, so someone has put it where the water is. Its roots go down to the stream, and so it bears fruit in season and its leaf does not wither. A person who is rooted in God's word is not immune to hardship, but he has resources the world does not see.

The wicked are like chaff, the light husk of the grain that blows away when the wheat is threshed. They have no weight and no roots. "The wicked will not stand in the judgment." The psalm ends with the contrast: the LORD knows the way of the righteous, and the way of the wicked will perish. To be known by the LORD is the ultimate security.

Read after Matthew 5 to 7, the psalm gets sharper. Who is the truly blessed man who perfectly delights in the law and never walks with sinners? Jesus. He is the true tree planted by the water, and he is the one who gives his Spirit so that others may be rooted in him. The Beatitudes echo this psalm's first word: "Blessed." The Sermon on the Mount is the same invitation to choose the path of life.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 17:7-8 uses the same tree image for the one who trusts in the LORD. John 15:5 says, "I am the vine; you are the branches. Whoever abides in me and I in him, he it is that bears much fruit." Matthew 7:24-27 is Jesus' version of the two ways. Joshua 1:8 commands meditating on the book of the law day and night. Colossians 2:6-7 says to be rooted and built up in him. Revelation 22:2 shows the tree of life by the river.

STEP 6

Application

Take five minutes today to meditate on one verse, not just read it. Turn it over and ask what it means.

Ask who or what is shaping your "counsel" right now: the voices you listen to and the company you keep.

Memorize verses 1 to 3 as a picture of the life you want.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to be a tree planted by streams of water.

Ask him to keep you from the counsel of the wicked.

Thank him that he knows your way.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 82

"In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven."

MATTHEW 5:16

DAY 574 · WEEK 82

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Matthew 5:16 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven."

MATTHEW 5:16

REST

Meditation

This verse comes at the end of Jesus' picture of his followers as the light of the world. It tells us what the light is for.

"In the same way." Jesus has just said that a lamp is not lit and hidden under a basket but put on a stand to give light to all in the house. His followers are like that. The point of a light is to be seen, and the point of being seen is to help others find their way.

"Let your light shine." The light is not manufactured. Jesus has already said, "You are the light of the world." The light comes from him, and he says elsewhere, "I am the light of the world." We reflect what we have received. Our task is not to produce it but to let it be seen and not to hide it out of fear or embarrassment.

“Before others.” Faith is not private only. It is lived in front of people, at work, at home, among neighbors. Others notice how we treat people, how we handle trouble, and how we speak.

“So that they may see your good works.” The good works are real, practical acts of love and honesty. They are the visible side of a changed heart.

“And give glory to your Father who is in heaven.” This is the goal. The aim of shining is not that people admire us, but that they look past us to the Father. Good works are windows, not mirrors. If someone praises you today, pass it up to him.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you walked through the opening of Matthew and the heart of the Sermon on the Mount. You saw Jesus’ birth announced with the name that means “the LORD saves,” the baptism where the Father called him his beloved Son, and the wilderness where Jesus beat the devil by quoting Scripture. In the Sermon, Jesus described the blessed life of kingdom people in the Beatitudes, called you salt and light, and showed what the law really demands: a clean heart, not just clean hands. He taught you to pray, to give and fast in secret, and to trust the Father instead of worrying. Then he asked you to choose between two roads and two foundations. Psalm 1 gave the same choice in older words.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said the poor in spirit are blessed. What would it look like for you to come to God this week with empty hands?

The Sermon shows that the law reaches the heart. In light of that, how does the gospel, that Christ fulfilled the law for us, change the way you read these chapters?

Jesus invites us to call God “Our Father.” What difference does it make to your prayer life, your worries, and your sense of identity to know that?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to let your light shine so that others give him glory.

Thank Jesus for fulfilling the law in your place.

Thank him that you can call him Father.

DAY 575 · WEEK 83

Psalm 146

Praise the LORD who executes justice, the Beatitudes' God

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 146. Read it as the Beatitudes in song form: a psalm about the God who blesses the poor, the hungry, and the oppressed. Notice the warning in verses 3 and 4 and the blessing in verse 5.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 146 is the first of the five closing Hallelujah psalms, and its theme matches the Sermon on the Mount you have just read. It is a praise song that centers on the character of God as the helper of the helpless. Jesus' opening words in the Sermon, "Blessed are the poor in spirit," sound much like this psalm's "Blessed is he whose help is the God of Jacob."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD, O my soul!" (v. 1).
2. "I will praise the LORD as long as I live" (v. 2).
3. "Put not your trust in princes, in a son of man, in whom there is no salvation" (v. 3).
4. "When his breath departs, he returns to the earth; on that very day his plans perish" (v. 4).
5. "Blessed is he whose help is the God of Jacob, whose hope is in the LORD his God" (v. 5).
6. "Who executes justice for the oppressed, who gives food to the hungry" (v. 7).
7. "The LORD opens the eyes of the blind" (v. 8).
8. "The LORD will reign forever, your God, O Zion, to all generations" (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with the writer talking to his own soul: “Praise the LORD, O my soul!” He decides to praise for as long as he lives. Then comes a warning: do not trust princes, mortals, or any human leader as your final hope. Their breath leaves them, they return to dust, and their plans die with them. This is not cynicism about human government but realism. No leader can save you.

The alternative is the God of Jacob. He made heaven and earth and the sea, and he keeps faith forever. That last line is the foundation of everything. God’s faithfulness is not temporary. And what does this God do? He executes justice for the oppressed, gives food to the hungry, sets prisoners free, opens the eyes of the blind, lifts up those who are bowed down, loves the righteous, watches over strangers, and upholds the widow and fatherless.

Now read the Gospels in this light. When Jesus heals the blind, feeds the hungry, and welcomes the outsiders in the chapters ahead, he is doing what this psalm says the LORD does. John the Baptist will ask from prison whether Jesus is the one who is to come, and Jesus will answer by pointing to the blind who see and the poor who hear good news. The psalm tells us what to look for.

The psalm ends with “the LORD will reign forever.” Princes die. The king lives. Our hope rests there.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 11:2-6 shows Jesus answering John with the very works this psalm describes. Luke 4:18-19 has Jesus reading Isaiah 61 about good news to the poor, liberty to captives, and sight to the blind. Isaiah 2:22 says to stop regarding man, whose breath is in his nostrils. Jeremiah 17:5-8 contrasts trust in man with trust in the LORD. James 1:27 says pure religion is to visit orphans and widows. Revelation 11:15 declares that he shall reign forever and ever.

STEP 6

Application

Think about where you might be putting too much trust in a leader, a party, or a system. Re-center your hope on the LORD.

Choose one group named in verses 7 to 9 (the hungry, the oppressed, the foreigner, the widow, the orphan) and do one concrete thing to help.

Praise the LORD out loud today, with your whole soul, for something specific.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God as long as you live, in your own words.

Confess where you trust in princes instead of him.

Thank him that he keeps faith forever and executes justice for the oppressed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 83

“Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.”

MATTHEW 11:28

DAY 576 · WEEK 83

Psalm 147:1-11

He heals the brokenhearted

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 147:1-11. You read all of Psalm 147 on Day 508 as a song for the rebuilt wall. Today read only the first eleven verses, and let them sit beside what Jesus does in the next chapters: healing the brokenhearted and binding up wounds.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first half of Psalm 147 pairs two pictures: God the builder and gatherer, and God the healer. It also tells us what pleases him. Read these verses today with the Gospel of Matthew open in your mind, where the Messiah begins to touch lepers, lift the paralyzed, and call the weary to himself.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Praise the LORD! For it is good to sing praises to our God” (v. 1).
2. “The LORD builds up Jerusalem; he gathers the outcasts of Israel” (v. 2).
3. “He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds” (v. 3).
4. “He determines the number of the stars; he gives to all of them their names” (v. 4).
5. “Great is our Lord, and abundant in power; his understanding is beyond measure” (v. 5).
6. “The LORD lifts up the humble; he casts the wicked to the ground” (v. 6).
7. “He gives to the beasts their food, and to the young ravens that cry” (v. 9).
8. “But the LORD takes pleasure in those who fear him, in those who hope in his steadfast love” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

On Day 508, you heard this psalm at the dedication of the wall. Today, notice what stands out about verse 3: “He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds.” Right after the gathering of the outcasts, the psalm turns to the personal. God does not only manage nations. He kneels to bandage individual hurts.

The next verse sets this beside the stars. The same God who counts and names the stars is the one who tends the brokenhearted. His power and his tenderness are not in competition. The Gospel of Matthew gives this a face. In the chapters you are about to read, Jesus touches a leper, raises a girl, and heals the sick. Matthew says that this fulfilled what Isaiah said: “He took our illnesses and bore our diseases.” The God of the stars came near to the broken.

Verses 10 and 11 tell us what God values. He does not delight in the strength of the horse or the legs of a man, which means military might and human physical power. He takes pleasure in those who fear him and hope in his steadfast love. God is not impressed by what we can do. He is moved by trust.

For a person who is hurting, this psalm is an invitation. You do not have to fix yourself before you come. The LORD heals the brokenhearted, and he does it because that is who he is.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 8:16-17 quotes Isaiah 53:4 about Jesus healing the sick. Matthew 11:28 calls the weary and burdened to come. Luke 4:18 says he has been sent to bind up the brokenhearted. Isaiah 61:1 is the source of that verse. Psalm 34:18 says the LORD is near to the brokenhearted. 2 Corinthians 1:3-4 calls God the Father of mercies and God of all comfort. Revelation 21:4 promises that he will wipe away every tear.

STEP 6

Application

Name one hurt you have been carrying. Bring it to the Lord in prayer without trying to tidy it first.

Look for someone brokenhearted near you and offer a quiet act of care: a call, a note, a meal.

Tonight, look at the stars and remember that the one who named them knows your name.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds.

Tell him what is broken in you.

Praise him for the stars he counts and names.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 83

“Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.”

MATTHEW 11:28

DAY 577 · WEEK 83

Matthew 8:1-9:38

Ten miracles, the King demonstrates the Kingdom's arrival

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 75 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 8:1-9:38. Matthew gathers ten miracles into two chapters: a leper, a centurion's servant, Peter's mother-in-law, a storm, two demon-possessed men, a paralytic, a dead girl, a woman with bleeding, two blind men, and a mute man. Read for what the miracles reveal about the King.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the Sermon on the Mount, in which Jesus spoke with authority, Matthew shows Jesus acting with authority. The Sermon was the King's words, and these chapters are the King's works. Each miracle demonstrates that the kingdom of heaven has arrived, and each shows power over a different enemy: disease, nature, demons, sin, and death. Alongside the miracles, Matthew places the cost of following him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Lord, if you will, you can make me clean" (8:2).
2. "Truly, I tell you, with no one in Israel have I found such faith" (8:10).
3. "This was to fulfill what was spoken by the prophet Isaiah: He took our illnesses and bore our diseases" (8:17).
4. "Foxes have holes, and birds of the air have nests, but the Son of Man has nowhere to lay his head" (8:20).
5. "What sort of man is this, that even winds and sea obey him?" (8:27).
6. "Take heart, my son; your sins are forgiven" (9:2).

7. “I desire mercy, and not sacrifice. For I came not to call the righteous, but sinners” (9:13).

8. “When he saw the crowds, he had compassion for them, because they were harassed and helpless, like sheep without a shepherd” (9:36).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first miracle is a leper, the most unclean person in Israel. The law said that a leper must keep away and cry “Unclean!” Yet Jesus touches him, and instead of Jesus becoming unclean, the man becomes clean. Then comes a Roman centurion, a Gentile, who recognizes that Jesus needs only to say the word. Jesus is amazed at his faith and says that many will come from east and west to sit at table with Abraham. The kingdom is wider than Israel.

On the Sea of Galilee, a storm threatens to sink the boat while Jesus sleeps. He rebukes the wind and the waves, and there is a great calm. The disciples ask, “What sort of man is this?” Only God commands the sea (Psalm 107:29). He then sends demons into pigs and heals a paralyzed man. Here the order is striking: he first says “Your sins are forgiven,” and only then heals the body. The scribes call it blasphemy, and they are right that only God can forgive sins. Jesus proves his authority by healing.

Matthew himself, the tax collector, is called to follow. Jesus eats with tax collectors and sinners and says he is a physician for the sick. Then a ruler’s daughter is raised, a woman’s bleeding is healed, the blind see, and the mute speak.

The section ends with Jesus’ compassion. He sees the crowds as sheep without a shepherd and says the harvest is plentiful but the laborers are few. The miracles are not displays. They show the heart of the Messiah, who has come to rescue and to gather.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 13 and 14 describe the laws for leprosy. Psalm 107:23-30 describes God calming the storm. Isaiah 53:4 is quoted in 8:17. Mark 2:1-12 gives a fuller account of the paralytic. Hosea 6:6 is quoted in 9:13. Ezekiel 34:5 describes shepherdless sheep. John 11:25: “I am the resurrection and the life.” Hebrews 4:15: we have a high priest who sympathizes with our weaknesses.

STEP 6

Application

Pray the leper’s prayer: “Lord, if you will, you can make me clean.” Name the specific thing you need cleansed or healed.

When storms come, remember that Jesus is in the boat. Say aloud, “Even the winds and sea obey him.”

Ask the Lord of the harvest to send workers, and ask whether you may be one.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus you believe, and ask him to help your unbelief.
- Ask him to make you clean where you need cleansing.
- Thank him for his power over storms, sin, and death.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 83

“Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.”

MATTHEW 11:28

DAY 578 · WEEK 83

Matthew 10:1-11:30

The Twelve sent; "Come to me, all who are weary"

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 10:1-11:30. Jesus sends out the Twelve and warns them about opposition. Then John the Baptist sends a question from prison, and Jesus ends the chapter with one of the most beloved invitations in the Bible. Read 11:28-30 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Having shown his compassion for the harassed crowds, Jesus calls twelve disciples and sends them to the lost sheep of Israel. The twelve apostles echo the twelve tribes: Jesus is gathering a renewed Israel. His instructions are honest about the cost. Then, in chapter 11, we see doubt and rejection, and Jesus responds with an invitation to the weary.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And he called to him his twelve disciples and gave them authority over unclean spirits" (10:1).
2. "These twelve Jesus sent out, instructing them, Go nowhere among the Gentiles and enter no town of the Samaritans, but go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel" (10:5-6).
3. "Behold, I am sending you out as sheep in the midst of wolves, so be wise as serpents and innocent as doves" (10:16).
4. "Whoever loves father or mother more than me is not worthy of me" (10:37).
5. "Whoever finds his life will lose it, and whoever loses his life for my sake will find it" (10:39).
6. "Are you the one who is to come, or shall we look for another?" (11:3).

7. “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest” (11:28).
8. “For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light” (11:30).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The commission is clear and costly. The disciples are to proclaim the kingdom, heal, and cast out demons, depending on others for hospitality. Jesus warns them that they will be hated, brought before governors, and divided from their families. Yet he repeats, “Do not be afraid,” because the Father who cares for the sparrows cares for them. Those who acknowledge him before people, he will acknowledge before his Father.

His words about family are hard: loving him above father and mother. This is not a call to hate one’s family, but a statement that he must come first. And the paradox: finding your life means losing it for his sake.

Then John the Baptist, in prison, sends a question. He had announced the coming judge, and now he is in a cell, and Jesus is healing and eating with sinners. He wonders, “Are you the one?” It is a very human doubt. Jesus does not rebuke him. He points to the works: the blind see, the lame walk, lepers are cleansed, the poor have good news. And he says, “Blessed is the one who is not offended by me.” He then praises John as the greatest of the prophets.

Jesus condemns the cities that saw miracles and did not repent. And then, to the surprise of the reader, he prays and offers an invitation. “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden.” The yoke is the picture of a teacher’s way of life. The Pharisees’ yoke was heavy with rules. Jesus’ yoke is gentle. His rest is not a break from work but a relationship in which he carries the weight with us.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 31:25 promises to satisfy the weary soul. Exodus 33:14 records God saying, “My presence will go with you, and I will give you rest.” Acts 15:10 calls the burden of the law a yoke that neither we nor our fathers could bear. Hebrews 4:9-11 speaks of a Sabbath rest for the people of God. Luke 14:26-33 teaches the cost of discipleship. Philippians 3:7-8 shows Paul counting all things as loss for Christ. 1 John 5:3: his commandments are not burdensome.

STEP 6

Application

If you are weary today, stop and take Jesus’ invitation personally. Tell him specifically what is heavy.

Think of a person who is doubting. Respond like Jesus did to John: patiently, with evidence of God's goodness.

Ask what it means to take his yoke and learn from him. What practice could you begin?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Come to Jesus weary and burdened, and tell him what weighs on you.

Ask him to teach you, for he is gentle and lowly in heart.

Take his yoke, and tell him what that means.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 83

"Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest."

MATTHEW 11:28

DAY 579 · WEEK 83

Matthew 12:1-13:23

Sabbath controversies; Beelzebul; the Sower

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 82 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 12:1-13:23. Jesus is Lord of the Sabbath, the Pharisees accuse him of working by Satan's power, and he tells the first parables. Pay close attention to the parable of the sower and Jesus' explanation.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Opposition has been building, and in chapter 12 it becomes open conflict. The Pharisees object to Jesus' disciples picking grain on the Sabbath and to his healing on the Sabbath. They then accuse him of casting out demons by Beelzebul. Jesus responds with arguments from Scripture and warnings. In chapter 13, he begins teaching in parables, stories that reveal the kingdom to those with ears to hear and conceal it from those who harden their hearts.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For the Son of Man is lord of the Sabbath" (12:8).
2. "I desire mercy, and not sacrifice" (12:7).
3. "Behold, my servant whom I have chosen, my beloved with whom my soul is well pleased" (12:18).
4. "If I cast out demons by the Spirit of God, then the kingdom of God has come upon you" (12:28).
5. "Whoever is not with me is against me" (12:30).
6. "For something greater than Solomon is here" (12:42).
7. "And he told them many things in parables, saying, A sower went out to sow" (13:3).

8 “As for what was sown on good soil, this is the one who hears the word and understands it. He indeed bears fruit” (13:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Sabbath conflicts reveal a clash between two ways of reading God’s law. The Pharisees saw rules to protect. Jesus saw mercy to practice. He cites David, who ate the consecrated bread when hungry, and the priests who work in the temple on the Sabbath. Then he says, “Something greater than the temple is here,” and that the Son of Man is lord of the Sabbath. This is a startling claim: he is the one who gave the Sabbath and the one to whom the Sabbath points.

Matthew quotes Isaiah’s servant song, showing a gentle servant who will not break a bruised reed. Then when Jesus casts out a demon, the Pharisees say he does it by the prince of demons. Jesus answers: a kingdom divided against itself cannot stand. If he casts out demons by the Spirit of God, then the kingdom has arrived. The unforgivable sin, blasphemy against the Spirit, is attributing the Spirit’s work to Satan, persistently and with a hardened heart. People who seek forgiveness have not committed it.

The parable of the sower begins chapter 13. A farmer scatters seed on four kinds of soil: the path, rocky ground, thorns, and good soil. The seed is the same. The difference is in the hearers. Some do not understand and the evil one snatches the word. Some receive it with joy but have no root. Some are choked by worries and wealth. And some hear, understand, and bear fruit. Jesus explains that parables reveal truth to those who are open and conceal it from those who are not.

The point is for you to ask which soil you are. The remedy for a hard heart is not to try harder but to ask the Sower to work on the soil.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 20:8-11 gives the Sabbath command. Hosea 6:6 is quoted in 12:7. Isaiah 42:1-4 is quoted in 12:18-21. Mark 3:28-30 gives a parallel to the warning about the Spirit. Isaiah 6:9-10 is quoted in 13:14-15 about hardened hearts. Hebrews 4:1-11 teaches Sabbath rest fulfilled in Christ. Colossians 2:16-17 says the Sabbath was a shadow of what was to come. James 1:21 says to receive with meekness the implanted word.

STEP 6

Application

Honestly ask which soil describes you right now. If the thorns of worry or wealth are choking the word, name them.

Remember that Jesus is Lord of the Sabbath. Receive rest as a gift from him, not a rule to earn.

Pray for someone close to you who seems hard or unresponsive to the gospel.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being Lord of the Sabbath.
- Ask him to break up hard ground in your heart.
- Ask him to help you bear fruit.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 83

“Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.”

MATTHEW 11:28

DAY 580 · WEEK 83

Psalm 78:1-16

He commanded our fathers to teach their children

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 16 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 78:1-16. This psalm begins with a teacher's voice and a plan to teach the next generation. Notice that the first verse is quoted in Matthew 13:35 as a reason Jesus spoke in parables.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 78 is a long historical poem, and its first sixteen verses introduce its purpose. Asaph invites the people to listen to a "parable," a teaching that recounts the exodus and the wilderness. Matthew applies the psalm's opening line to Jesus: "I will open my mouth in parables; I will utter what has been hidden since the foundation of the world." Jesus was telling the story of God's people in a new way.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give ear, O my people, to my teaching; incline your ears to the words of my mouth!" (v. 1).
2. "I will open my mouth in a parable; I will utter dark sayings from of old" (v. 2).
3. "We will not hide them from their children, but tell to the coming generation the glorious deeds of the LORD" (v. 4).
4. "He established a testimony in Jacob and appointed a law in Israel" (v. 5).
5. "That the next generation might know them, the children yet unborn" (v. 6).
6. "So that they should set their hope in God and not forget the works of God" (v. 7).
7. "The Ephraimites, armed with bows, turned back on the day of battle" (v. 9).

8 “He divided the sea and let them pass through it, and made the waters stand like a heap” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a lesson in how faith is passed on. The speaker says that what we have heard and known, and what our fathers told us, we will not hide from our children. God commanded the fathers to teach their children, so that each generation would know and set hope in God, and not be like their stubborn ancestors. The goal is not information alone, but hope, remembrance, and obedience.

Then the psalm gives a negative example: the Ephraimites, who were armed and yet turned back in battle because they “did not keep God’s covenant.” They forgot his works. The rest of the psalm, which you will read later, is a catalog of Israel’s forgetfulness.

The first verses of the history begin with the exodus. God divided the sea, led them with a cloud by day and fire by night, and split rocks in the wilderness to give them water “abundantly as the deep.” These are wonders that should have inspired lasting trust.

Matthew quotes the psalm’s opening in 13:35 to explain Jesus’ parables. The parable of the Sower came right before. Jesus was now doing what Asaph said: opening his mouth in parables and uttering what had been hidden. And the content was the story of Israel retold. The King was both the teacher and the fulfillment of the story.

For parents, teachers, and the children’s ministry, this psalm is a charter. The purpose of teaching is that the next generation will “set their hope in God.” Tell the stories. Do not hide them.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 13:34-35 quotes verse 2 as fulfilled in Jesus. Deuteronomy 6:6-7 commands teaching the words of God to your children. Exodus 14 and 17 are the events recalled. Proverbs 22:6 says to train up a child in the way he should go. 2 Timothy 1:5 and 3:14-15 describe faith passed through grandmother and mother. Ephesians 6:4 tells fathers to bring up their children in the discipline and instruction of the Lord. Joel 1:3: tell your children of it.

STEP 6

Application

Tell one younger person, a child, a grandchild, a student, or a new believer, a story of what God has done.

Write down three works of God in your own life, so you will not forget them.

If you serve with children, pray for the next generation to set their hope in God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you pass on what you have heard and known.

Confess where you hide his deeds from the next generation.

Thank him for those who taught you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 83

“Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.”

MATTHEW 11:28

DAY 581 · WEEK 83

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Matthew 11:28 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest."

MATTHEW 11:28

REST

Meditation

This invitation comes right after Jesus has condemned cities that would not repent, and right after he has said that the Father has revealed these things to little children. It is addressed to people who know they are tired.

"Come to me." Jesus does not say, "Come to a system," or "Come to my teaching." He says, "Come to me." Rest is found in a person. The invitation is personal, direct, and present. You are not asked to improve first.

"All who labor and are heavy laden." "Labor" means to be worn out from toil, and "heavy laden" means loaded down. It includes the weariness of trying to earn God's favor, the weight of guilt, the burden of grief, and the sheer tiredness of life in a fallen world. The invitation is for "all." No one is excluded.

“And I will give you rest.” The word “give” is crucial. Rest is a gift. It is not wages. Jesus gives soul rest: peace with God, relief from the need to prove ourselves, and a settled place in him. In the next verses, he says that his yoke is easy and his burden light.

This verse is for the weary Christian as well as the seeker. Keep it near. When you are exhausted by life or by trying to be good enough, hear him say it to you again: Come.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed Jesus through the Sermon’s conclusion and into his works. You learned from Psalm 1 and Matthew 7 that there are two roads and two foundations. In Psalms 146 and 147, you praised the God who helps the helpless and heals the brokenhearted, and in Matthew 8 and 9 you saw Jesus do exactly that: cleansing a leper, calming a storm, forgiving a paralytic, and raising a girl. You saw him send out the Twelve, answer John’s doubt with works, and invite the weary to come to him. You watched the opposition grow as he declared himself Lord of the Sabbath, and you heard the parable of the sower. Psalm 78 reminded you to pass the stories of God’s deeds to the next generation.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said, “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden.” What weights are you carrying that you have not yet brought to him?

Jesus forgave the paralytic’s sins before healing his body. Why do you think he started there, and what does that say about our deepest need?

The parable of the sower asks what kind of soil we are. What is one practical way you can prepare your heart to receive and keep the word this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Come to Jesus tired and burdened, and thank him for the rest he gives.

Ask him to heal what is broken.

Ask him to forgive what needs forgiving.

DAY 582 · WEEK 84

Psalm 25

Make me to know your ways, O LORD

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 25. This is a prayer of David, an acrostic, in which he asks God to teach him his ways. Read it as a disciple's prayer, the prayer of someone who wants to learn from the Master.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 25 is a prayer of someone in trouble, surrounded by enemies and burdened by guilt, who turns to God for guidance and forgiveness. It is arranged as an acrostic, with each line starting with the next Hebrew letter. Coming after Jesus' call to "learn from me," it works as a prayer of discipleship: "Make me to know your ways, O LORD; teach me your paths."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "To you, O LORD, I lift up my soul" (v. 1).
2. "Make me to know your ways, O LORD; teach me your paths" (v. 4).
3. "Lead me in your truth and teach me, for you are the God of my salvation" (v. 5).
4. "Remember not the sins of my youth or my transgressions; according to your steadfast love remember me" (v. 7).
5. "Good and upright is the LORD; therefore he instructs sinners in the way" (v. 8).
6. "He leads the humble in what is right, and teaches the humble his way" (v. 9).
7. "The friendship of the LORD is for those who fear him, and he makes known to them his covenant" (v. 14).
8. "Turn to me and be gracious to me, for I am lonely and afflicted" (v. 16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with trust: “To you, I lift up my soul.” The soul is lifted like a hand, in dependence. The psalmist asks not to be put to shame and says that those who wait on the LORD will not be.

Then comes the core request, repeated in several forms: show me your ways, teach me your paths, lead me in your truth. Notice the humility. David the king asks to be taught. He knows that guidance is not automatic, and that he needs God to show him the way. And the ground of his hope is not his own merit. He says, “You are the God of my salvation.”

He asks God to forget the sins of his youth and remember him according to steadfast love. This is the language of grace. David knows his past. He asks to be dealt with by God’s mercy, not by his record. “For your name’s sake, O LORD, pardon my guilt, for it is great.” He does not minimize his sin.

The central insight is verse 8: “Good and upright is the LORD; therefore he instructs sinners in the way.” God teaches sinners. The qualification for a student is not being good already but being humble. “He leads the humble in what is right.”

Verse 14 is a gem: “The friendship of the LORD is for those who fear him.” The word for friendship can be “intimacy” or “confidential counsel.” God shares his secrets with those who revere him. The psalm ends with a plea for rescue and for the redemption of Israel from all his troubles. It is a model for a new believer who wants to learn.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 11:29: “Learn from me, for I am gentle and lowly in heart.” John 15:15: “I have called you friends.” Proverbs 3:5-6 says to trust in the LORD and he will make your paths straight. James 1:5 promises wisdom to those who ask. Psalm 119:105 says his word is a lamp to our feet. Isaiah 30:21 promises a voice saying, “This is the way, walk in it.” Romans 8:1: there is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.

STEP 6

Application

Make verses 4 and 5 your daily morning prayer for a week.

Bring a specific decision to God and ask him to show you the way. Listen through his word.

Confess one sin from your past that still weighs on you, and trust his steadfast love to remember you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Lift up your soul to God, and tell him what you want to know of his ways.

Ask him to lead you in his truth.

Ask him not to remember the sins of your youth.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 84

"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."

MATTHEW 17:5

DAY 583 · WEEK 84

Matthew 13:24-14:36

Kingdom parables; John beheaded; the feeding

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 13:24-14:36. Jesus tells more parables of the kingdom, is rejected in Nazareth, and hears of John's death. Then he feeds five thousand and walks on the sea. Notice Peter in the boat.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The parables of Matthew 13 explain what the kingdom is like now that the King is here. It is not what many expected, an immediate military takeover. It begins small, grows slowly, and exists alongside evil until the end. Then the narrative moves quickly: Jesus is rejected at home, John the Baptist is killed, and the crowds are fed. In each scene, the identity of Jesus is the question.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The kingdom of heaven is like a grain of mustard seed that a man took and sowed in his field" (13:31).
2. "The kingdom of heaven is like leaven that a woman took and hid in three measures of flour" (13:33).
3. "The kingdom of heaven is like treasure hidden in a field, which a man found and covered up. Then in his joy he goes and sells all that he has and buys that field" (13:44).
4. "Is not this the carpenter's son?" (13:55).
5. "And he did not do many mighty works there, because of their unbelief" (13:58).
6. "They took up his body and buried it, and they went and told Jesus" (14:12).
7. "You give them something to eat" (14:16).

8 “Take heart; it is I. Do not be afraid” (14:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The parables of the weeds, mustard seed, and leaven teach that the kingdom starts small and spreads quietly, and that good and evil grow together until the harvest. The wheat and the weeds will be separated at the end, and not before. This protects us from two errors: trying to purify the church by force, and thinking that evil has won.

The treasure and the pearl show the worth of the kingdom. A man finds treasure and sells everything for joy. This is not grudging sacrifice but delighted exchange. Following Jesus costs everything, and it is worth it.

Then comes rejection. In his hometown, the people take offense at him: “Is not this the carpenter’s son?” Familiarity breeds contempt. Matthew says he did not do many works there because of unbelief.

When Jesus hears about John’s death, he withdraws to a quiet place, but the crowds follow. He has compassion and heals them. In the evening, the disciples want to send the people away. Jesus says, “You give them something to eat.” With five loaves and two fish, he feeds five thousand men, besides women and children, with twelve baskets left over. It echoes the manna in the wilderness and anticipates the Lord’s Supper.

Then Jesus sends the disciples ahead in the boat and goes up to pray. In the storm he comes walking on the sea, which only God does (Job 9:8). Peter steps out, walks, sees the wind, and begins to sink. “Lord, save me.” Jesus catches him. The disciples worship: “Truly you are the Son of God.”

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 2:34-35 and 44-45 compare the kingdom to a stone that becomes a mountain. Ezekiel 17:22-24 uses the image of a tree where birds nest. Philippians 3:7-8 shows Paul counting all things as loss for Christ. Exodus 16 describes manna in the wilderness. Job 9:8 says God alone treads on the waves of the sea. Psalm 77:19 says God’s way was through the sea. John 6:35: “I am the bread of life.” Hebrews 12:2 says to look to Jesus.

STEP 6

Application

Think of the kingdom like treasure. Is there something you are holding too tightly that you would be glad to exchange for it?

When Jesus says, “You give them something to eat,” ask what small thing you can offer. He can multiply it.

When you start to sink, say Peter’s prayer: “Lord, save me.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus what you are holding too tightly.
- Ask him to teach you to treasure the kingdom above all.
- Thank him for feeding you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 84

“This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him.”

MATTHEW 17:5

DAY 584 · WEEK 84

Matthew 15:1-16:28

Defilement; Peter's confession; the cross predicted

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 15:1-16:28. Jesus teaches what really defiles a person, heals a Gentile woman's daughter, feeds four thousand, and asks the disciples who they say he is. Peter's confession is the center of the Gospel. Read 16:13-28 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The conflict with the Pharisees continues. Jesus turns away from the hand-washing traditions to the heart. He then travels into Gentile territory, where he meets a woman of great faith. Then, in the region of Caesarea Philippi, he asks the question that changes everything. From that point on, Matthew says, Jesus begins to show the disciples that he must go to Jerusalem and suffer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "This people honors me with their lips, but their heart is far from me" (15:8).
2. "What comes out of the mouth proceeds from the heart, and this defiles a person" (15:18).
3. "Woman, great is your faith! Be it done for you as you desire" (15:28).
4. "Beware of the leaven of the Pharisees and Sadducees" (16:6).
5. "Who do you say that I am?" (16:15).
6. "You are the Christ, the Son of the living God" (16:16).
7. "And I tell you, you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it" (16:18).

8 “If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me” (16:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus says that defilement is not about unwashed hands or food. It is about the heart. Evil thoughts, murder, adultery, theft, and slander all come from within. This was shocking to people who defined holiness by external rules. The real problem is inside, and only God can change it.

The Canaanite woman is a surprising example of faith. She is a Gentile who cries out to the Son of David. Jesus tests her, and she persists with humility: even dogs eat the crumbs from the table. Jesus commends her: “Great is your faith!” A foreigner understands what the leaders of Israel do not.

Then comes the pivot. Jesus asks who people say he is, and then, “Who do you say that I am?” Peter answers, “You are the Christ, the Son of the living God.” This is the memory verse of the unit. Christ means the Messiah, the anointed king. Jesus says that this was revealed to Peter by the Father. On this confession, Jesus will build his church, and not even death’s gates will stand against it. Whether “the rock” refers to Peter, to his confession, or both, the church rests on the truth that Jesus is the Christ.

But immediately Jesus begins to explain that the Christ must suffer, be killed, and be raised. Peter rebukes him, and Jesus calls him Satan, a stumbling block, for setting his mind on the things of man. Then the call goes out to all: deny yourself, take up your cross, and follow. “Whoever loses his life for my sake will find it.” The Christ is a crucified Christ, and his followers walk the same road.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 29:13 is quoted in 15:8. Mark 7:14-23 adds that Jesus declared all foods clean. Romans 10:9 says if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him, you will be saved. Ephesians 2:20 says the household of God is built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Christ Jesus himself being the cornerstone. Galatians 2:20: “I have been crucified with Christ.” Luke 9:23 adds “daily.” Hebrews 12:2.

STEP 6

Application

Answer Jesus’ question in your own words: “Who do you say that I am?” Write it down.

Ask where your heart is far from God while your lips are near. Bring that to him.

Think about what taking up your cross looks like in your current season.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess with Peter who you believe Jesus is.
- Ask him to cleanse your heart from the inside.
- Ask him to teach you what it means to take up your cross.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 84

"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."

MATTHEW 17:5

DAY 585 · WEEK 84

Matthew 17:1-18:35

The Transfiguration; greatness and forgiveness

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 17:1-18:35. Jesus is transfigured on the mountain, the Father speaks, and then Jesus teaches about greatness, discipline, and forgiveness. Read the Transfiguration in light of the end of chapter 16.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Six days after Peter's confession and Jesus' first prediction of his death, Jesus takes Peter, James, and John up a high mountain. There his appearance changes, and Moses and Elijah, the law and the prophets, appear and speak with him. It is a glimpse of his glory, given to strengthen the disciples for the road to the cross. Then, in chapter 18, Jesus gives teaching on life in the community of the kingdom.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And he was transfigured before them, and his face shone like the sun, and his clothes became white as light" (17:2).
2. "And behold, there appeared to them Moses and Elijah, talking with him" (17:3).
3. "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him" (17:5).
4. "Jesus came and touched them, saying, Rise, and have no fear" (17:7).
5. "If you have faith like a grain of mustard seed, you will say to this mountain, Move from here to there, and it will move" (17:20).
6. "Unless you turn and become like children, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven" (18:3).
7. "For where two or three are gathered in my name, there am I among them" (18:20).

8 “I do not say to you seven times, but seventy-seven times” (18:22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

On the mountain, the disciples see the glory that is usually hidden. Jesus shines like the sun, and Moses and Elijah, who both met God on a mountain, speak with him. Luke tells us they spoke of his “departure,” literally his exodus, which he was about to accomplish at Jerusalem. The law and the prophets bear witness to Jesus and his coming death.

Peter wants to build three tents, but a cloud covers them, and the Father says almost the same words as at the baptism, with an addition: “Listen to him.” Moses and Elijah fade away. Jesus alone remains. The Law and the Prophets point to him, and now the voice of heaven says that he is the one to hear. When they look up, they see only Jesus.

Coming down, they find the disciples failing to heal a boy, and Jesus tells them that even a small faith moves mountains. He again predicts his death and resurrection.

In chapter 18, Jesus teaches that greatness in the kingdom belongs to the humble like children. He warns about causing little ones to stumble and tells the story of the lost sheep: the Father does not want any to perish. He then gives a process for restoring a sinning brother, and promises his presence where two or three gather in his name.

Peter asks how often to forgive, and Jesus says seventy-seven times. The parable of the unforgiving servant follows, a man forgiven a huge debt who refuses to forgive a small one. The lesson is that those who have been forgiven much must forgive. The mercy we have received is the pattern and power for the mercy we give.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 34:29-35 shows Moses’ face shining. 2 Peter 1:16-18 recalls Peter’s witness of this event. Luke 9:31 mentions the exodus Jesus would accomplish. Deuteronomy 18:15 promises a prophet like Moses to whom Israel should listen. Hebrews 1:1-2 says God has spoken to us by his Son. Colossians 3:13: “As the Lord has forgiven you, so you also must forgive.” Ephesians 4:32. Revelation 1:12-18.

STEP 6

Application

Listen to Jesus this week. Read a Gospel passage slowly, with the sense that the Father is saying, “Listen to him.”

Think of someone who has wronged you. Consider the size of your own forgiven debt, and take a step toward forgiveness.

Seek out a small child or a humble person and learn something about trust.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you listen to his beloved Son.

Thank him for showing his glory to strengthen you.

Ask him to make you someone who forgives.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 84

"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."

MATTHEW 17:5

DAY 586 · WEEK 84

Psalm 2

You are my Son, the voice at the Transfiguration

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 2. The Father's voice at the baptism and the Transfiguration drew on this psalm: "You are my Son." Read it as the coronation of the Messiah, and notice the warning and the invitation at the end.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 2 is a royal psalm, probably first used at the crowning of a king in the line of David. It has four parts: the nations plot (vv. 1-3), God laughs from heaven (vv. 4-6), the king declares God's decree (vv. 7-9), and the nations are warned to submit (vv. 10-12). The New Testament sees its full meaning in Jesus. After the Transfiguration, it gives the background to the Father's words.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain?" (v. 1).
2. "The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the LORD and against his Anointed" (v. 2).
3. "He who sits in the heavens laughs; the Lord holds them in derision" (v. 4).
4. "As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill" (v. 6).
5. "You are my Son; today I have begotten you" (v. 7).
6. "Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage, and the ends of the earth your possession" (v. 8).
7. "Now therefore, O kings, be wise; be warned, O rulers of the earth" (v. 10).
8. "Blessed are all who take refuge in him" (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a question that every generation has asked: why do the nations rage against God? Rulers conspire against the LORD and his Anointed. They want to throw off his rule: “Let us burst their bonds apart.” The scene is of human defiance.

Heaven’s reaction is surprising. God laughs. It is not a cheerful laugh but the scorn of one whose throne is not threatened. Human rebellion is real, but it does not unseat him. He has already installed his king on Zion.

Then the king speaks. He announces the decree: “You are my Son; today I have begotten you.” In the ancient world, a king was adopted as God’s son on the day of his coronation. For David’s line, this was a title and a covenant. For Jesus, it is more. At his baptism and Transfiguration, the Father spoke these words about him, and Hebrews 1:5 applies it to his resurrection and enthronement. He is the Son in a unique sense.

The Son is promised the nations as his inheritance, and he will rule them with a rod of iron. The psalm does not hide that the Messiah’s reign includes judgment on those who persist in rebellion.

Yet the psalm ends with an invitation. Kings are told to be wise, to serve the LORD with fear, and to “kiss the Son,” a gesture of homage, “lest he be angry.” The final line is a beatitude: “Blessed are all who take refuge in him.” The same Son who will judge is the refuge for all who come to him. The Sermon began with “Blessed”; Psalm 1 began with “Blessed”; Psalm 2 ends with “Blessed.” The choice is to resist him or take refuge in him.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 4:25-28 quotes this psalm about the plot against Jesus. Acts 13:33 applies verse 7 to the resurrection. Hebrews 1:5 and 5:5 quote verse 7. Revelation 2:26-27 and 19:15 allude to the iron rod. Matthew 3:17 and 17:5 echo verse 7. Philippians 2:9-11 says every knee will bow. Romans 1:4 says Jesus was declared to be the Son of God in power by his resurrection from the dead.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether any part of your life is in rebellion against his rule. Surrender it.

When the news feels chaotic and the nations rage, remember that God has set his King on Zion.

Take refuge in the Son. Name a fear or burden, and say aloud, “I take refuge in him.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what rage and plotting you see in the world.
- Thank him for the Son he has enthroned.
- Take refuge in him, and say so.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 84

"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."

MATTHEW 17:5

DAY 587 · WEEK 84

Psalm 110

The LORD says to my Lord, Melchizedek and priesthood

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 110. This is the Old Testament psalm quoted most often in the New Testament. Jesus used it in Matthew 22 to ask the Pharisees a question they could not answer. Read it as the portrait of a king who is also a priest.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 110 is a short psalm of David, only seven verses. It records a conversation within God: the LORD speaks to David's Lord. It describes a king who sits at God's right hand and a priest forever in the order of Melchizedek. Today you read it after Psalm 2 and the Transfiguration, and just before Jesus uses it in the temple.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD sends forth from Zion your mighty scepter. Rule in the midst of your enemies!" (v. 2).
3. "Your people will offer themselves freely on the day of your power" (v. 3).
4. "The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind: You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek" (v. 4).
5. "The Lord is at your right hand; he will shatter kings on the day of his wrath" (v. 5).
6. "He will execute judgment among the nations" (v. 6).
7. "He will drink from the brook by the way; therefore he will lift up his head" (v. 7).

8 “He will execute judgment among the nations, filling them with corpses; he will shatter chiefs over the wide earth” (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first verse is a puzzle. David, the king, calls someone “my Lord.” The LORD (Yahweh) speaks to this other Lord and invites him to sit at his right hand, the place of highest honor and authority. Who is this? A king calls no one lord except God. Yet this figure is also David’s descendant. In Matthew 22:41-46, Jesus asks the Pharisees exactly this: if the Christ is David’s son, how does David call him Lord? They have no answer. The answer is that the Messiah is both David’s son and David’s Lord, fully human and fully divine.

The psalm describes his reign. He rules from Zion in the midst of his enemies. His people come willingly, “in holy garments,” ready to serve. His enemies become his footstool.

Then verse 4 gives the second puzzle: this king is also a priest forever. In Israel, kings came from Judah and priests from Levi, and the two offices were kept apart. But Melchizedek was both king of Salem and priest of God Most High, who blessed Abraham in Genesis 14. The psalm says the Messiah will be a priest like him, not by genealogy, but by God’s oath. And it is an oath God will not change.

Hebrews builds its whole argument on this verse. Jesus is the priest who offered himself once for all, and is now seated at God’s right hand, where he intercedes for us. He is not standing like the Old Testament priests, whose work was never done. He sits because his work is finished.

The psalm ends with the king refreshed and lifting up his head, a picture of victory. After the Transfiguration and before the passion week, this psalm sets the course: the Son will suffer, be raised, and reign.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 22:41-46 records Jesus’ question about this psalm. Acts 2:33-36 applies it to the ascension. Hebrews 5:5-10, 7:1-28, and 10:11-14 explain Melchizedek and Christ’s priesthood. Genesis 14:18-20 introduces Melchizedek. Romans 8:34: Christ Jesus is at the right hand of God, interceding for us. 1 Corinthians 15:25 says he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. Colossians 3:1.

STEP 6

Application

Remember today that Jesus is seated at the Father’s right hand, in authority, praying for you.

When you feel guilty, remember that your priest is the perfect one who has offered the final sacrifice.

Offer yourself willingly to his service today, as the psalm says his people do.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship Jesus as David's son and David's Lord.
- Thank him that he is a priest forever.
- Ask him to make his enemies his footstool in your life too.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 84

"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."

MATTHEW 17:5

DAY 588 · WEEK 84

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Matthew 17:5 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."

MATTHEW 17:5

REST

Meditation

The Father spoke these words from a bright cloud on the mountain. Peter had just suggested building three tents, one for Jesus, one for Moses, and one for Elijah. The Father interrupted him.

"This is my beloved Son." The Father identifies Jesus. He is not a prophet among prophets or a teacher among teachers. He is the Son, and the Father loves him. This is the same voice that spoke at the baptism, now speaking to the disciples directly.

"With whom I am well pleased." The Father delights in the Son. Jesus' obedience, his life, and his mission please the Father. And because we are in Christ, the Father's delight in the Son reaches us.

"Listen to him." This is the addition, and it is a command. Moses and Elijah, the law and the prophets, were great. But now the final word has come in the Son. Hebrews 1:1-2 says that God spoke in many ways long ago by the prophets, but in these last days he has spoken to us

by his Son. We are not to listen to Jesus alongside other equal voices. We are to listen to him above all.

What does it mean to listen to him? Not just to hear, but to obey. The disciples fell on their faces in fear, and Jesus came and touched them and said, “Rise, and have no fear.” The one we are told to listen to is gentle. When you read the Gospels this week, imagine the Father saying, “Listen to him.”

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you moved from the quiet parables to the great confession. You heard Jesus teach that the kingdom starts small, like a mustard seed, and is worth more than all you own. You watched him feed five thousand and walk on the sea, and you saw Peter step out and sink. You read that defilement comes from the heart, that a Gentile woman showed great faith, and that Peter confessed, “You are the Christ, the Son of the living God.” You saw Jesus begin to speak of the cross and call his followers to take up theirs. On the mountain you saw him transfigured, and heard the Father say, “Listen to him.” You then learned about humility, correction, and forgiveness. The psalms framed it: Psalm 25 asked to be taught, Psalm 2 crowned the Son, and Psalm 110 showed a king and priest at God’s right hand.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Peter confessed that Jesus is the Christ, and almost immediately rebuked him for talking about the cross. Where are you tempted to want a Jesus without a cross?

The Father said, “Listen to him.” What does listening to Jesus look like in your daily routine?

Jesus told Peter to forgive seventy-seven times. Whom do you find hardest to forgive, and how does knowing how much you have been forgiven change that?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you listen to his beloved Son and obey.

Thank him for the glory shown and the cross carried.

Rest in him.

DAY 589 · WEEK 85

Matthew 19:1-20:34

Marriage, children, wealth; servant leadership

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 63 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 19:1-20:34. Jesus teaches on marriage, children, and wealth, then tells the parable of the workers in the vineyard. He predicts his death a third time and heals two blind men. Read 20:25-28 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus has left Galilee and is traveling toward Jerusalem. Along the road, he teaches about the shape of kingdom life: faithfulness in marriage, welcome for the vulnerable, freedom from the grip of money, and a radical idea of greatness. The shadow of the cross grows longer, and the disciples still do not understand.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “What therefore God has joined together, let not man separate” (19:6).
2. “Let the little children come to me and do not hinder them, for to such belongs the kingdom of heaven” (19:14).
3. “If you would be perfect, go, sell what you possess and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven; and come, follow me” (19:21).
4. “It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich person to enter the kingdom of God” (19:24).
5. “With man this is impossible, but with God all things are possible” (19:26).
6. “But many who are first will be last, and the last first” (19:30).
7. “Are you envious because I am generous?” (20:15).

8 “Whoever would be great among you must be your servant… even as the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many” (20:26-28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

On marriage, Jesus goes back to Genesis. God made them male and female, and the two become one flesh. Divorce was permitted by Moses because of hardness of hearts, but it was not the original design. Jesus takes marriage seriously, as a covenant joined by God.

When parents bring children for blessing, the disciples try to send them away. Jesus rebukes them. The kingdom belongs to those who receive it with a child’s openness and dependence.

The rich young man is a tragic scene. He has kept the commandments, and he asks what he still lacks. Jesus lovingly tests his heart: sell what you have, give to the poor, and follow me. The man goes away sorrowful, for he had great wealth. His possessions had hold of him. Jesus tells the disciples how hard it is for the rich to enter the kingdom, and when they ask who can be saved, he says, “With man this is impossible, but with God all things are possible.” Salvation is a gift of God’s power, not something we manage. Peter asks what the disciples will get, and Jesus promises great reward, and then warns that the first will be last.

The vineyard parable makes the point. Workers hired at the last hour receive the same pay as those who worked all day. The owner says, “Are you envious because I am generous?” God’s grace is not wages. It is a gift.

Then comes the third prediction of death, and immediately two disciples ask for the best seats. Jesus redefines greatness. In the world, leaders lord it over others. In the kingdom, the great one serves. And he gives himself as the model: the Son of Man came to give his life as a ransom for many. This is the key to the Gospel.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:27 and 2:24 are quoted in 19:4-5. Mark 10:17-31 gives a parallel to the rich young ruler. Philippians 2:5-8 describes the servant-hearted mind of Christ. 1 Timothy 6:17-19 teaches the rich to be generous. Isaiah 53:10-12 describes the suffering servant who bears the sin of many. 1 Peter 1:18-19 says we were ransomed by the precious blood of Christ. Ephesians 2:8-9 says salvation is a gift of God, not a result of works.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you would find hardest to give up if Jesus asked. Pray about it honestly.

Welcome a child or a person of low status this week in a way that costs you something.

Practice servant leadership in one place where you have influence: at home, at work, or at church.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for giving his life as a ransom for you.
- Ask him to free you from the love of money or status.
- Ask him to teach you to serve.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 85

"You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind."

MATTHEW 22:37

DAY 590 · WEEK 85

Matthew 21:1-22:14

The Triumphal Entry; Temple cleansing; the wicked tenants

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 21:1-22:14. Jesus enters Jerusalem on a donkey, cleanses the temple, curses a fig tree, is challenged on his authority, and tells three parables of judgment. Read the entry in light of Zechariah 9:9, which you memorized last unit.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the beginning of the final week of Jesus' earthly life. He enters Jerusalem to the shouts of the crowds, and what follows is a series of confrontations in and around the temple. The religious leaders, who see him as a threat, try to trap him. Jesus responds with parables that expose their rejection of God's messengers and of his Son.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, your king is coming to you, humble, and mounted on a donkey" (21:5).
2. "Hosanna to the Son of David! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord!" (21:9).
3. "My house shall be called a house of prayer, but you make it a den of robbers" (21:13).
4. "By what authority are you doing these things?" (21:23).
5. "But when the tenants saw the son, they said to themselves, This is the heir. Come, let us kill him and have his inheritance" (21:38).
6. "The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone" (21:42).
7. "Therefore I tell you, the kingdom of God will be taken away from you and given to a people producing its fruits" (21:43).
8. "For many are called, but few are chosen" (22:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus plans his entry. He sends for a donkey and a colt, and Matthew says this fulfilled the prophecy of Zechariah 9:9, the verse you memorized at the end of Unit 14. The king comes humble and on a donkey. The crowds spread cloaks and branches, and shout “Hosanna,” which means “save us,” quoting Psalm 118. They see him as the Son of David.

He goes straight to the temple and drives out the merchants. The temple was meant to be a house of prayer for all nations, and it had become a marketplace. He heals the blind and lame there, and the children shout his praise, while the leaders are indignant.

The cursed fig tree is a parable in action. It had leaves, which promised fruit, but no fruit. It pictures a religion with outward show and no reality. The leaders then challenge his authority, and he answers with a question about John’s baptism that they cannot answer without exposing themselves.

The parable of the two sons shows that tax collectors and prostitutes are entering the kingdom ahead of the religious leaders, because they repented. The parable of the wicked tenants is the clearest. The landowner sends servants, who are beaten and killed, and finally he sends his son. The tenants kill him to seize the inheritance. Jesus quotes Psalm 118: the stone the builders rejected becomes the cornerstone. The leaders perceive that he is speaking about them.

The wedding feast is the last parable. Those invited refuse, and the invitation goes out to everyone. But one man arrives without a wedding garment, and he is cast out. The garment pictures what God provides for entry. “Many are called, but few are chosen.”

STEP 5

Connection

Zechariah 9:9 and Psalm 118:25-26 stand behind the entry. Isaiah 56:7 and Jeremiah 7:11 are quoted at the temple cleansing. Isaiah 5:1-7 is the background to the vineyard parable. Psalm 118:22-23 is the cornerstone passage, also cited in Acts 4:11 and 1 Peter 2:4-8. Isaiah 61:10 speaks of being clothed with garments of salvation. Revelation 19:7-9 describes the marriage supper of the Lamb. Galatians 3:27: as many as were baptized into Christ have put on Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Welcome Jesus as the king who comes humbly. Is there an area where you want a more impressive king?

Ask whether your life has leaves without fruit. What is one practical step toward real fruit?

Think about the wedding garment: are you trusting in your own righteousness or in the clothing Christ provides?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Say “Hosanna” to the Son of David, and tell him why.
- Thank him for coming humbly to Jerusalem.
- Ask him to cleanse the temple of your own heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 85

“You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind.”

MATTHEW 22:37

DAY 591 · WEEK 85

Matthew 22:15-23:39

Controversies; the greatest commandment; woes to scribes

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 22:15-23:39. The leaders test Jesus with questions about taxes, the resurrection, and the greatest commandment. Then Jesus turns the tables and pronounces seven woes on the scribes and Pharisees. Read 22:34-40 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The final week in the temple courts is a series of tests. First the Pharisees and Herodians ask about taxes to Caesar, then the Sadducees ask about the resurrection, and then a lawyer asks about the greatest commandment. Jesus answers all of them with wisdom. Then he asks the question that silences his opponents, and he turns to the crowds and disciples to warn them about the hypocrisy of their leaders.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar’s, and to God the things that are God’s” (22:21).
2. “You are wrong, because you know neither the Scriptures nor the power of God” (22:29).
3. “He is not God of the dead, but of the living” (22:32).
4. “You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind” (22:37).
5. “On these two commandments depend all the Law and the Prophets” (22:40).
6. “The Lord said to my Lord, Sit at my right hand” (22:44).
7. “They preach, but do not practice” (23:3).

8 “Whoever exalts himself will be humbled, and whoever humbles himself will be exalted” (23:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus answers the question about taxes with wisdom. The coin bears Caesar’s image, so give it to Caesar. But humans bear God’s image, so give yourselves to God. The Sadducees, who deny the resurrection, bring a trick question, and Jesus answers from the Scriptures they accept: God said, “I am the God of Abraham,” and he is the God of the living. The resurrection is rooted in who God is.

The lawyer asks which commandment is the greatest. Jesus gives two: love God with everything, and love your neighbor as yourself. All the law and the prophets hang on these. This is not a replacement for the law but its summary. The whole of the Old Testament is about love of God and neighbor.

Then Jesus asks his question about Psalm 110. If the Christ is David’s son, how does David call him Lord? No one could answer, and from that day, no one dared to ask him any more questions. The Messiah is both human and divine.

Chapter 23 is the most severe passage in the Gospels. Jesus warns the crowds and his disciples about the scribes and Pharisees. They sit on Moses’ seat, so their teaching from Scripture should be heeded, but their practice should not be imitated. They love honor, burden people with rules, and neglect justice, mercy, and faithfulness. “Woe to you, hypocrites!” occurs again and again. They clean the outside of the cup and are full of greed inside. They are whitewashed tombs.

Yet the chapter ends with sorrow, not just anger: “O Jerusalem, Jerusalem… How often would I have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you were not willing!” The judgment comes from a broken heart. Even so, he promises that they will say, “Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord.”

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 6:5 and Leviticus 19:18 are the two commandments quoted. Exodus 3:6 is quoted about the God of the living. Psalm 110:1 is the psalm you read on Day 587. Micah 6:8 sums up justice, kindness, and walking humbly. Romans 13:8-10 says love is the fulfilling of the law. 1 John 4:19-21: we love because he first loved us. Luke 13:34-35 has the lament over Jerusalem. Philippians 2:3.

STEP 6

Application

Practice the two great commandments today: choose one concrete act of love for God and one for a neighbor.

Check yourself for hypocrisy: where do you say one thing and do another?

Remember that Jesus grieves over those who refuse him. Pray for someone who resists the gospel.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask Jesus to teach you to love God with all your heart, soul, and mind.
- Ask him to help you love a specific neighbor.
- Ask him to keep you from the hypocrisy he warns about.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 85

"You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind."

MATTHEW 22:37

DAY 592 · WEEK 85

Matthew 24:1-25:46

The Olivet Discourse; virgins, talents, sheep and goats

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 97 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 24:1-25:46. This is the Olivet Discourse, followed by three parables: the ten virgins, the talents, and the sheep and goats. It is a long reading, so take it in three parts. Notice the repeated call to watch and be ready.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

As Jesus leaves the temple, the disciples point out its buildings. He says that not one stone will be left on another. Later, on the Mount of Olives, they ask when this will happen and what will be the sign of his coming and the close of the age. Jesus' answer includes the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70, and it also looks further to his return. The point of the chapters is not to give a timetable but to call for readiness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "See that no one leads you astray. For many will come in my name, saying, I am the Christ" (24:4-5).
2. "But the one who endures to the end will be saved" (24:13).
3. "And this gospel of the kingdom will be proclaimed throughout the whole world as a testimony to all nations, and then the end will come" (24:14).
4. "Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away" (24:35).
5. "But concerning that day and hour no one knows, not even the angels of heaven, nor the Son, but the Father only" (24:36).
6. "Watch therefore, for you do not know on what day your Lord is coming" (24:42).

7. “Well done, good and faithful servant. You have been faithful over a little; I will set you over much” (25:21).

8. “Truly, I say to you, as you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me” (25:40).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The discourse mixes near and far. Jesus warns of false messiahs, wars, famines, persecution, and the abomination of desolation, details that were fulfilled in part in the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70. He also speaks of his coming “like lightning” and the gathering of his elect. Scholars differ on how to divide the near and far. What is clear is the pattern: before the end there will be trouble, the gospel will go to all nations, and no one will know the day.

The repeated call is to be ready. The faithful servant is the one found working when the master returns. This is not paranoia but steady faithfulness.

Three parables apply the point. The ten virgins: five were wise and took extra oil, and five were foolish. When the bridegroom came at midnight, the foolish ones were shut out. Readiness cannot be borrowed at the last minute. The talents: a master entrusts money to three servants and goes away. Two invest and double it, and the third buries his out of fear. The master praises faithfulness and condemns the one who did nothing. We are to use what Jesus has entrusted to us.

The sheep and goats is the final scene of judgment. The Son of Man sits on his throne and separates the nations. The sheep are those who fed the hungry, welcomed the stranger, clothed the naked, and visited the sick and imprisoned, and they did so to Jesus without knowing it. The goats failed to do so. The standard is not a list of achievements but the fruit of a changed heart: love shown to the least of these, who are Christ’s brothers.

The discourse ends on a note of both warning and hope. The King will return. Those who are his will be welcomed into the kingdom prepared for them since the foundation of the world.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 7:13-14 and 9:27 stand behind the language of the Son of Man and the abomination. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-5:11 describes the Lord’s return and the call to be awake. 2 Peter 3:8-13 explains the delay. Luke 19:11-27 gives a similar parable of the minas. James 2:14-17 says faith without works is dead. Revelation 20:11-15 depicts the final judgment. Titus 2:13 speaks of waiting for the blessed hope.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you have been entrusted with, such as time, gifts, resources, and relationships. How can you invest it for the King?

Do one concrete act of mercy for “the least of these” this week.

Live ready, not fearful: do today’s work faithfully, knowing that he is coming.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus you are watching and ready, or ask him to make you so.
- Ask him for the faithfulness that lasts like oil in a lamp.
- Ask him to show you how to care for the least of these.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 85

“You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind.”

MATTHEW 22:37

DAY 593 · WEEK 85

Psalm 118

Blessed is he who comes in the name of the LORD

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Psalm · 29 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 118. This is the last of the Hallel psalms, which Jews sang at Passover. It was likely sung by Jesus and the disciples on the night of the Last Supper. Read it as the psalm of the week you have just entered.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 118 is a thanksgiving liturgy for a king who has been delivered. Verses 22 to 29 were part of what the crowds shouted on Palm Sunday. Jesus quoted it in the parable of the tenants. The Hallel (Psalms 113 to 118) was sung at Passover, which makes it very likely that this was the last hymn Jesus sang before Gethsemane (Matthew 26:30).

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!” (v. 1).
2. “Out of my distress I called on the LORD; the LORD answered me and set me free” (v. 5).
3. “The LORD is on my side; I will not fear. What can man do to me?” (v. 6).
4. “It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man” (v. 8).
5. “The LORD is my strength and my song; he has become my salvation” (v. 14).
6. “I shall not die, but I shall live, and recount the deeds of the LORD” (v. 17).
7. “The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone” (v. 22).
8. “Blessed is he who comes in the name of the LORD!” (v. 26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins and ends with the same refrain: “Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good.” Between those lines, a man who has been surrounded and nearly killed tells how God rescued him. “All nations surrounded me; in the name of the LORD I cut them off!” He was pushed hard, but the LORD helped him. “The LORD has disciplined me severely, but he has not given me over to death.”

Then he asks to enter the gates of righteousness to give thanks, and the main verses follow. The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone. This is the Lord’s doing, and it is marvelous in our eyes. In the original setting, it probably referred to Israel, once despised by the nations, or to the Davidic king. In the New Testament it is applied to Jesus. The builders, the leaders of Israel, rejected him, and God made him the cornerstone of the new temple.

Then the crowd’s words: “Save us, we pray, O LORD!” (Hosanna) and “Blessed is he who comes in the name of the LORD!” On Palm Sunday, the crowd shouted these words to Jesus. They did not yet understand how he would save. The one who comes in the LORD’s name would enter the gates of Jerusalem and go to a cross.

Think about Jesus singing this psalm on the night he was betrayed. “The LORD is on my side; I will not fear.” “I shall not die, but I shall live.” “Bind the festal sacrifice with cords, up to the horns of the altar!” The psalm of the rejected stone was sung by the rejected stone, on his way to be rejected.

And it ends with praise. “You are my God, and I will give thanks to you.” The cross is not the end.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 21:9, 21:42, and 23:39 quote this psalm. Matthew 26:30 says that after singing a hymn they went out to the Mount of Olives. Acts 4:11-12 and 1 Peter 2:6-8 apply the cornerstone to Jesus. Ephesians 2:20-22 describes the household of God built on the cornerstone. Romans 8:31: if God is for us, who can be against us? Hebrews 13:6 quotes verse 6. Hebrews 12:2.

STEP 6

Application

Sing or read Psalm 118:1 and 29 as a frame for your day. Begin and end with thanks.

Remember a time when God brought you out of distress. Tell someone about it.

Pray verse 25, “Save us, we pray,” for your church and for someone who needs rescue.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God for his steadfast love.
- Tell him: “The LORD is on my side; I will not fear.”
- Thank him for the stone the builders rejected.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 85

“You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind.”

MATTHEW 22:37

DAY 594 · WEEK 85

Matthew 26:1-46

The plot; the anointing; the Last Supper; Gethsemane

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 46 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 26:1-46. The plot against Jesus, the anointing at Bethany, Judas's betrayal, the Last Supper, Peter's denial predicted, and Gethsemane. Read the words of institution (26:26-29) and the prayer in the garden (26:36-46) slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is Passover week. The religious leaders are plotting to arrest Jesus quietly. At the same time, a woman anoints him with costly perfume, Judas bargains to betray him, and Jesus shares the Passover meal with his disciples. In the garden afterward, he prays in anguish. Matthew shows that everything is happening according to the Scriptures, and that Jesus goes to the cross willingly.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You know that after two days the Passover is coming, and the Son of Man will be delivered up to be crucified" (26:2).
2. "Why this waste? For this could have been sold for a large sum and given to the poor" (26:8-9).
3. "What will you give me if I deliver him to you?" (26:15).
4. "Take, eat; this is my body" (26:26).
5. "For this is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins" (26:28).
6. "Even if I must die with you, I will not deny you" (26:35).
7. "My soul is very sorrowful, even to death; remain here, and watch with me" (26:38).

8 “My Father, if it be possible, let this cup pass from me; nevertheless, not as I will, but as you will” (26:39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter moves between devotion and betrayal. A woman pours an expensive jar of ointment on Jesus’ head, and the disciples object to the waste. Jesus defends her: she has prepared him for burial, and her act will be remembered. Immediately afterward, Judas goes to the chief priests and sells Jesus for thirty pieces of silver. The price recalls Zechariah 11:12, the price of a slave.

At the Passover meal, Jesus predicts that one of them will betray him. Each asks, “Is it I, Lord?” Then he takes bread and wine and gives them new meaning. The bread is his body and the cup is his blood of the covenant, poured out for the forgiveness of sins. This is the new covenant promised in Jeremiah 31. The Passover lamb saved Israel from judgment, and Jesus is the Lamb whose blood saves his people. He also promises that he will drink it new with them in the Father’s kingdom.

On the way to the Mount of Olives, he tells the disciples that they will all fall away. Peter protests that he will never deny him. Jesus says that before the rooster crows, he will deny him three times.

In Gethsemane, we see Jesus in anguish. “My soul is very sorrowful, even to death.” He falls on his face and prays, “Let this cup pass from me.” The cup is the cup of God’s wrath against sin. Yet he adds, “Not as I will, but as you will.” The second Adam, in a garden, submits to the Father’s will where the first Adam rebelled. He prays three times, and the disciples sleep. Then he stands: “Rise, let us be going; see, my betrayer is at hand.”

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 12 describes the first Passover. Jeremiah 31:31-34 promises the new covenant. Zechariah 11:12-13 and 13:7 are fulfilled in the thirty pieces and the scattering of the sheep. Isaiah 51:17 describes the cup of the LORD’s wrath. Hebrews 5:7-8 describes Jesus’ prayers with loud cries and tears. 1 Corinthians 11:23-26 gives Paul’s account of the Lord’s Supper. Genesis 3 and Romans 5:19 contrast Adam’s disobedience with Christ’s obedience. Luke 22:44.

STEP 6

Application

If you are able, take the Lord's Supper this week, and think about what "the forgiveness of sins" cost him.

In your own Gethsemane, whatever that may be, pray as Jesus did: "Not as I will, but as you will."

Ask where you have said, "I will never deny you," and been overconfident.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for the bread and cup given for the forgiveness of your sins.
- Ask him to keep you awake and praying when you are tempted to sleep.
- Tell him what cup you are afraid to drink, and pray, "Not my will but yours."

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 85

"You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind."

MATTHEW 22:37

DAY 595 · WEEK 85

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Matthew 22:37 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind."

MATTHEW 22:37

REST

Meditation

A lawyer tried to test Jesus with a question: which commandment in the law is the greatest? Jesus quoted the Shema from Deuteronomy 6, the words every Jewish child learned.

"You shall love." The center of the law is love. Love is a command, which means it is a settled direction of the will as well as a feeling. We are commanded because love is owed, and because God knows our hearts will wander if left alone.

"The Lord your God." The object of love is the Lord, and he is our God, in covenant relationship. He is not an idea or a force. He is a person who has made himself known and who loves us first.

"With all your heart." The heart in Hebrew thought is the center of the person, including will and desire. To love with all the heart is to desire God above all.

“And with all your soul.” The soul is the whole life. To love with all the soul is to give our lives and energy to him.

“And with all your mind.” The mind is our thinking and understanding. Christianity is not anti-intellectual. We are meant to think about God and his word, and to love him with our minds.

The whole person is to be engaged. Nothing is left over. This is the great and first commandment, and Jesus says that the second is like it: love your neighbor as yourself. No one has ever fully kept it except Jesus. He loved the Father perfectly and loved us to the cross. Say this verse each morning and ask him to grow your love.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you walked with Jesus toward Jerusalem and into Holy Week. You heard his teaching on marriage, children, and wealth, and saw the rich young man walk away. You learned that greatness in the kingdom means serving, since the Son of Man came to give his life as a ransom for many. You watched the king enter Jerusalem on a donkey, clean out the temple, and tell parables about wicked tenants and a wedding feast. You heard the two great commandments and the seven woes. In the Olivet Discourse, he called you to be ready: like the wise virgins, faithful servants, and those who serve the least of these. Psalm 118 gave you the words the crowds sang and Jesus likely sang that final night. At the Last Supper, he gave you his body and blood of the new covenant, and in Gethsemane he prayed, “Not as I will, but as you will.”

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus summed up the law in two commandments: love God and love neighbor. Which of the two do you find harder right now, and why?

In the parable of the sheep and goats, the righteous served Christ without realizing it. Who are “the least of these” near you, and what is one concrete way to serve them?

At the Last Supper, Jesus said his blood is poured out “for the forgiveness of sins.” What does it mean to you personally that he drank the cup of judgment for you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask Jesus to help you love God with all your heart and your neighbor as yourself.

Thank him for the cup he drank for you.

Rest in him.

DAY 596 · WEEK 86

Matthew 26:47-27:31

Arrest; trials before the Sanhedrin and Pilate

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 26:47-27:31. Jesus is arrested, tried by the Sanhedrin, denied by Peter, handed over to Pilate, and mocked by soldiers. Watch how Jesus responds to each trial, and contrast his behavior with that of Peter and Judas.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is the night and early morning of Good Friday. Jesus is arrested in the garden by a crowd sent by the chief priests, led by Judas. He is taken to the high priest Caiaphas, where he is tried at night. At dawn he is delivered to the Roman governor Pilate, because only Rome could carry out a death sentence. The man who had healed and taught is now abandoned, mocked, and condemned.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Friend, do what you came to do” (26:50).
2. “Put your sword back into its place. For all who take the sword will perish by the sword” (26:52).
3. “Do you think that I cannot appeal to my Father, and he will at once send me more than twelve legions of angels?” (26:53).
4. “I adjure you by the living God, tell us whether you are the Christ, the Son of God” (26:63).
5. “You have said so. But I tell you, from now on you will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power” (26:64).
6. “And he went out and wept bitterly” (26:75).

7. “I have sinned by betraying innocent blood” (27:4).
8. “His blood be on us and on our children” (27:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Everything in the arrest shows that Jesus is in control. He tells Peter to put away his sword. He could call twelve legions of angels, but then the Scriptures could not be fulfilled. He goes willingly. All the disciples flee.

Before the Sanhedrin, the trial is a sham. False witnesses cannot agree. Finally the high priest asks under oath if he is the Christ. Jesus answers by combining Psalm 110 and Daniel 7: he will be seen seated at the right hand of Power and coming on the clouds of heaven. The high priest tears his robes and declares blasphemy. The council spits on him and strikes him. Jesus is condemned for telling the truth about who he is.

Meanwhile, Peter denies him three times as Jesus predicted, and when the rooster crows, he goes out and weeps bitterly. Judas, too, is filled with remorse and returns the silver, saying, “I have sinned.” But he goes and hangs himself. The difference between Peter and Judas is not in their sin but where they turned. Peter would later be restored. Judas despaired. True repentance turns to Christ and is met by his mercy.

Before Pilate, Jesus is silent when accused. Pilate knows that the leaders delivered him up out of envy. His wife sends a message: “Have nothing to do with that righteous man.” Pilate offers to release Barabbas or Jesus. The crowd chooses Barabbas, a criminal. The innocent one takes the guilty man’s place. Pilate washes his hands and has Jesus flogged. The soldiers mock him with a scarlet robe, a crown of thorns, and a reed scepter, and kneel to him in mockery. They did not know they were saying the truth: here is the King.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 53:7 says “like a lamb that is led to the slaughter… he opened not his mouth.” Psalm 22:7-8 describes the mocking. Daniel 7:13-14 and Psalm 110:1 stand behind Jesus’ answer. 1 Peter 2:21-24 says Christ suffered for you, leaving you an example. 2 Corinthians 5:21: for our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin. Luke 22:61-62 adds that the Lord turned and looked at Peter. Galatians 3:13. Hebrews 12:2-3.

STEP 6

Application

Place yourself in Peter’s sandals. Where have you denied Jesus by silence or by fear? Bring it to him, and know that he restores.

Consider Barabbas: Jesus took the place of a guilty man. You are Barabbas. Let that humble and move you.

Notice the silence of Jesus before his accusers, and ask the Spirit to give you patience when you are misjudged.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for going willingly to be arrested for you.

Confess where you have denied him.

Ask him to restore you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 86

"Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age."

MATTHEW 28:19-20

DAY 597 · WEEK 86

Matthew 27:32-66

The crucifixion; the burial, the King dies for his people

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 35 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 27:32-66. Jesus is crucified, mocked, abandoned, and dies. The temple curtain is torn, the earth shakes, and a centurion confesses. Read this slowly and quietly. Then notice the burial and the guard at the tomb.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is led to Golgotha, "the place of a skull," and crucified between two robbers. Matthew tells the story with restraint, but with signs that show its cosmic meaning. Darkness covers the land, the temple veil splits, the earth quakes, and the dead are raised. The King dies for his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And over his head they put the charge against him, which read, This is Jesus, the King of the Jews" (27:37).
2. "He saved others; he cannot save himself. He is the King of Israel; let him come down now from the cross, and we will believe in him" (27:42).
3. "Now from the sixth hour there was darkness over all the land until the ninth hour" (27:45).
4. "Eli, Eli, lema sabachthani? That is, My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (27:46).
5. "And Jesus cried out again with a loud voice and yielded up his spirit" (27:50).
6. "And behold, the curtain of the temple was torn in two, from top to bottom" (27:51).
7. "Truly this was the Son of God!" (27:54).

8 “Make it as secure as you can” (27:65).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The mocking is cruel and ironic. The leaders say, “He saved others; he cannot save himself.” They are right in a way they do not realize. He did not save himself precisely because he was saving others. The sign over his head, “King of the Jews,” is written as a mockery and is true.

At noon, darkness falls over the land for three hours. At the ninth hour, Jesus cries, “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” This is the opening of Psalm 22. It is the cry of one bearing the weight of sin. The Son who has never been separated from the Father experiences the abandonment that we deserve. This is the heart of the atonement. He bore the wrath for his people.

Then he yields up his spirit. Matthew records what follows. The temple curtain, which separated the Holy of Holies from the people, is torn from top to bottom, by God. The way into God’s presence is open. The earth shakes, the rocks split, and tombs open: the power of death is broken. A Roman centurion who watched him die says, “Truly this was the Son of God!” The first confession after the cross is from a Gentile.

Women who followed Jesus watch from a distance. Joseph of Arimathea, a rich disciple, asks Pilate for the body, wraps it in clean linen, and lays it in his own new tomb. The chief priests, who remembered that Jesus said he would rise on the third day, ask Pilate for a guard and seal the stone. They do all they can to keep him in the grave. But human security cannot stop God’s plan.

The chapter ends in silence. It is Saturday. The King is dead and buried. The disciples are scattered. And the reader holds their breath.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 22 describes the crucifixion in detail, from the cry of abandonment to the mocking and the casting of lots. Isaiah 53:4-6 and 10-12 describe the servant bearing our sins. Hebrews 10:19-22 says that through the curtain, that is, his flesh, we have confidence to enter the holy places. Galatians 3:13 says Christ became a curse for us. Romans 5:8. 1 Peter 3:18. 2 Corinthians 5:21. Mark 15:39 gives the centurion’s confession.

STEP 6

Application

Spend a few minutes in silence with this chapter. Let the weight of it settle.

Say aloud, “He did this for me,” and thank him specifically.

Because the curtain is torn, come boldly into God’s presence in prayer today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being forsaken so that you never would be.
- Tell him what it means that he bore your sin and the wrath you deserved.
- Sit in silence for a moment, and let it settle.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 86

“Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age.”

MATTHEW 28:19-20

DAY 598 · WEEK 86

Matthew 28:1-20

The resurrection; the Great Commission, all authority, all nations

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Reading · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 28:1-20. The women find the tomb empty, the risen Jesus meets them, the guards are bribed, and Jesus commissions his disciples on a mountain. This is the climax of the Gospel. Read the Great Commission aloud.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Early on the first day of the week, Mary Magdalene and the other Mary go to the tomb. Matthew's Gospel, which began with "God with us," ends with the risen Lord promising to be with his people always. The same Jesus who was rejected and killed now claims all authority in heaven and on earth.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And behold, there was a great earthquake, for an angel of the Lord, descending from heaven… rolled back the stone and sat on it" (28:2).
2. "He is not here, for he has risen, as he said. Come, see the place where he lay" (28:6).
3. "So they departed quickly from the tomb with fear and great joy, and ran to tell his disciples" (28:8).
4. "Do not be afraid; go and tell my brothers to go to Galilee, and there they will see me" (28:10).
5. "And when they saw him they worshiped him, but some doubted" (28:17).
6. "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me" (28:18).
7. "Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" (28:19).

8 “And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age” (28:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The resurrection is announced by the angel: “He has risen, as he said.” The tomb is empty, and the grave clothes are no longer needed. The women are told to go and tell the disciples. On the way, Jesus meets them, and they take hold of his feet and worship him. Notice that he calls the disciples “my brothers,” even after they abandoned him. He is gracious to those who failed.

The guards report to the chief priests, who bribe them to say the disciples stole the body. Matthew notes that this story was still spread among the Jews “to this day.” The empty tomb was too well known to deny. The only alternative was to invent a story. The resurrection is a fact that must be explained.

On the mountain in Galilee, the eleven see him and worship, though some doubt. Jesus does not rebuke them. He draws near and speaks. His words are the climax of the Gospel. First, authority: “All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me.” This is the fulfillment of Daniel 7:13-14, where the Son of Man receives dominion over all peoples. Then a command: make disciples of all nations. The mission that began with Abraham, “in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed,” now goes out to the world. The method is baptizing and teaching them to obey all that Jesus commanded. Finally, a promise: “I am with you always, to the end of the age.”

The book has come full circle. It began with Immanuel, “God with us,” and ends with “I am with you.” The King has conquered death, and his people are sent out in his authority and presence.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 7:13-14 is the background to “all authority.” Genesis 12:3 promised blessing for all families. Romans 1:4 says Jesus was declared to be the Son of God in power by his resurrection. 1 Corinthians 15:3-8 lists the appearances. Acts 1:8 repeats the commission. Isaiah 7:14 and Matthew 1:23 give Immanuel. Ephesians 1:20-22 describes Christ raised and seated above all rule. Revelation 7:9. John 20:21.

STEP 6

Application

Celebrate. Say aloud, “He is risen,” and let it be joy.

Think of one person you can invite or encourage to follow Jesus. Take a small step this week.

When you doubt, as some did, remember that Jesus came to them and spoke. Ask him to draw near.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise Jesus that he is risen as he said.

Thank him for all authority and the promise to be with you always.

Ask him to send you to someone to share his good news.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 86

"Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age."

MATTHEW 28:19-20

DAY 599 · WEEK 86

Deuteronomy 6:4; Matthew 28:18-20; 2 Corinthians 13:14

The Trinity

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Deuteronomy 6:4, Matthew 28:18-20, and 2 Corinthians 13:14. Today is a doctrinal pause on the Trinity. Notice that Deuteronomy says God is one, and the two New Testament verses name the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit together.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Bible never uses the word "Trinity," but it teaches the truth the word describes. In Deuteronomy, Israel confesses, "The LORD our God, the LORD is one." In the Great Commission, Jesus tells us to baptize in the singular "name" of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. Paul ends 2 Corinthians with a blessing that names all three. The church has summarized this teaching in its creeds.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one" (Deuteronomy 6:4).
2. "Baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" (Matthew 28:19).
3. "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me" (Matthew 28:18).
4. "Teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you" (Matthew 28:20).
5. "And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age" (Matthew 28:20).
6. "The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ" (2 Corinthians 13:14).
7. "And the love of God" (2 Corinthians 13:14).

8 “And the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all” (2 Corinthians 13:14).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Trinity is the biblical teaching that there is one God who eternally exists as three distinct persons, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, who are each fully God, and who share one divine essence. The persons are not three gods, and they are not three modes or masks of one person. The Father is not the Son, the Son is not the Spirit, and the Spirit is not the Father, yet there is one God. The persons are equal in glory and eternal, and they relate to one another in love: the Father eternally begets the Son, and the Spirit eternally proceeds from the Father and the Son. In salvation, the Father plans and sends, the Son accomplishes redemption, and the Spirit applies it.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Start with Deuteronomy 6:4, the Shema. Israel’s creed was that the LORD is one. In a world of many gods, this was the foundation of Israel’s faith. The New Testament does not abandon it. Instead it reveals that this one God has a fuller inner life than Israel knew.

In Matthew 28:19, Jesus commands baptism “in the name” (singular) of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. A single name for three persons, side by side, as equals. If the Son and the Spirit were mere creatures, to place them alongside the Father in this way would be blasphemy. Jesus also claims “all authority in heaven and on earth,” and promises to be present everywhere with his people always, which only God can do.

In 2 Corinthians 13:14, Paul names the three together in a blessing. He does not explain it, but assumes it. The blessing is the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit. Each person gives something, and all are equally God. Similar patterns appear throughout the New Testament, at Jesus’ baptism (the Father speaks, the Son is baptized, the Spirit descends), and in Ephesians 1, where the Father chooses, the Son redeems, and the Spirit seals.

Why does this matter? First, it means that God is love in himself. Before creation, the Father, Son, and Spirit shared perfect love. God did not need us to be loving. Second, it means that salvation is the work of the whole Trinity. Third, it means that when we worship Jesus, we are not violating monotheism, and when we pray by the Spirit we are speaking with God. The doctrine is a mystery, something we receive and adore, not something we fully comprehend. But it is the shape of the gospel.

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:1-3 and 14 reveal the Word who was with God and was God. John 14:16-17 mentions the Father, Son, and the Spirit as another Helper. Genesis 1:26 says “Let us make man.” Matthew 3:16-17 shows all three at Jesus’ baptism. Ephesians 1:3-14 sets out the work of each person. Romans 8:9-11 speaks of the Spirit of God and the Spirit of Christ. 1 Peter 1:2. Isaiah 6:8. Hebrews 9:14.

STEP 6

Application

Pray to each person of the Trinity this week: thank the Father for his love, the Son for his grace, and the Spirit for his fellowship.

Use the blessing in 2 Corinthians 13:14 to end a prayer or bless a loved one.

Resist the urge to reduce the Trinity to a neat illustration. Worship the mystery.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship the Father, Son, and Spirit, one God, in your own words.
- Thank the Father for his love, the Son for his grace, and the Spirit for his fellowship.
- Ask them to help you know each more.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 86

“Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age.”

MATTHEW 28:19-20

DAY 600 · WEEK 86

Matthew 28:18-20; Romans 6:1-4; Acts 2:38-41; Colossians 2:11-12

The Sacraments, Baptism

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 28:18-20, Romans 6:1-4, Acts 2:38-41, and Colossians 2:11-12. Today is a doctrinal pause on baptism. Notice what each passage says baptism pictures and what it commits us to.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus commanded baptism as part of making disciples. The early church practiced it from the first day: in Acts 2, three thousand were baptized after Peter's sermon. In his letters, Paul explains what baptism means. Christians have disagreed about some aspects of baptism, particularly about who should be baptized and the mode. This lesson focuses on what the Scriptures say about its meaning, and notes where traditions differ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" (Matthew 28:19).
2. "Do you not know that all of us who have been baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death?" (Romans 6:3).
3. "We were buried therefore with him by baptism into death" (Romans 6:4).
4. "So that… we too might walk in newness of life" (Romans 6:4).
5. "Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins" (Acts 2:38).
6. "And you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit" (Acts 2:38).

7. “So those who received his word were baptized, and there were added that day about three thousand souls” (Acts 2:41).

8. “Having been buried with him in baptism, in which you were also raised with him through faith in the powerful working of God” (Colossians 2:12).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Baptism is the sign, commanded by Christ, of entrance into the new covenant community. It pictures union with Christ in his death and resurrection, the washing away of sin, and the gift of the Spirit, and it publicly marks a person as belonging to the triune God and his people. Baptism does not save by itself; salvation comes by grace through faith. But baptism is not optional, for it is Christ’s command and the normal response of faith. Christians have differed on whether the proper subjects are believers only, or also the infant children of believers, and on the mode of baptism. Reformed churches have held both views. All agree that baptism is a gift to be received with faith and that it points to Christ.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Baptism begins with a command. After the resurrection, Jesus told the disciples to make disciples by baptizing and teaching. It is not an extra for the especially devoted but a normal part of becoming a disciple. It is done in the name of the triune God, which means the person is brought under the ownership and protection of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Romans 6 gives the central meaning. Paul is answering the question, “Should we continue in sin that grace may abound?” He says no, because in baptism we were united with Christ in his death and burial, and raised to walk in newness of life. Baptism is a picture of the gospel: death to the old life and resurrection to the new. Colossians 2:11-12 says the same: buried with him in baptism and raised with him through faith. The faith is key. Baptism is a sign of what God does for those who believe.

On the day of Pentecost, Peter says to repent and be baptized for the forgiveness of sins, and promises the gift of the Spirit. Baptism goes with repentance and faith. Notice that the promise is “for you and for your children,” which is where the different traditions find support for their practice. Those who baptize only professing believers see baptism as the outward sign of an inward faith that has already begun. Those who baptize infants of believers see it as a covenant sign like circumcision, promising what God will do. Both agree that the sign is empty without faith and that the reality is Christ.

For a new believer, baptism is a joyful step. If you have not been baptized, talk with your pastor. If you have, remember it: you were marked as Christ’s.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 17:9-14 describes circumcision as the sign of the old covenant. Galatians 3:26-29 says all who are baptized into Christ have put on Christ. 1 Peter 3:21 says baptism now saves you as an appeal to God for a good conscience through the resurrection of Jesus. Acts 8:36-39 and 16:31-34 record baptisms. Titus 3:5. Ephesians 4:4-6 speaks of one Lord, one faith, one baptism. Mark 16:16.

STEP 6

Application

If you have not been baptized, speak to a pastor or leader about it this week.

If you have been baptized, remember the day, and thank God for the promise it signified.

When you struggle with sin, remember Romans 6: you are united with Christ, dead to sin and alive to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for baptism and what it shows about your washing and new life.
- Tell him where you need to remember your baptism.
- Pray for those who have not been baptized.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 86

"Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age."

MATTHEW 28:19-20

DAY 601 · WEEK 86

Review and Reflection

Unit 15 review, The New Covenant Inaugurated, Matthew

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "You are the Christ, the Son of the living God."
>
> MATTHEW 16:16

REST

Meditation

Peter spoke these words in the region of Caesarea Philippi, a place full of temples to pagan gods. Jesus had asked, "Who do you say that I am?" and Peter answered for the group.

"You are the Christ." The word means the Anointed One, the Messiah, the king who was promised to David and for whom Israel had waited. Peter is saying that all the Old Testament hopes are fulfilled in Jesus. Everything you read in the Old Testament, the promised seed, the prophet like Moses, the son of David, the servant, and the king, was pointing to him.

"The Son of the living God." This phrase goes further. "Son of God" was a title for the king, but Peter's words, heard with the later Gospel, mean more. And he says "the living God," in contrast to the dead idols all around. Jesus is the Son of the one real, living God.

Jesus answered that this was not revealed by flesh and blood but by the Father in heaven. Faith is a gift. If you confess Jesus as the Christ, the Son of the living God, it is because the Father has opened your eyes.

And on this confession, Jesus said he would build his church. The church is a community of people who say what Peter said. Carry this sentence with you as the center of the whole unit. Every chapter of Matthew is meant to bring you to say it from the heart.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

Unit 15 opened the New Testament with Matthew's Gospel, and it showed that Jesus is the one for whom the whole Old Testament was waiting. His genealogy gathered Abraham and David. He was the new Israel, called out of Egypt, baptized in the Jordan, and tested in the wilderness, where he answered every temptation with Scripture. He was the new Moses, who gave the Sermon on the Mount from a mountain, showing that the law was always aimed at the heart and that he came to fulfill it, not abolish it. He taught us to pray to our Father, to seek first the kingdom, and to build our lives on the rock. His miracles showed the kingdom's power over disease, nature, demons, sin, and death, and his parables showed that it begins small and grows. Peter confessed that he is the Christ, the Son of the living God, and Jesus began to teach that the Christ must suffer. On the mountain the Father said, "Listen to him." In Jerusalem he rode in as the humble king, taught the two great commandments, and warned of judgment. At the Last Supper he gave his body and blood for the new covenant. At the cross, he bore the Father's wrath, the veil was torn, and the way into God's presence was opened. On the third day he rose and sent his disciples to all nations with all authority and with his presence. Two doctrinal days taught the Trinity and baptism. The King has come, and the kingdom has been inaugurated. The rest of the New Testament shows how it spreads.

REFLECT

Review Questions

How does Matthew's genealogy establish Jesus as the fulfillment of the OT covenants?

Think of Matthew 1:1 and the three sets of fourteen. What do Abraham and David represent, and why do the four women matter?

What does the Sermon on the Mount reveal about the relationship between law and gospel?

Think of the Beatitudes for the poor in spirit, the demand to go beyond the letter of the law in 5:21-48, and the impossible standard in 5:48. How does it drive us to Christ?

What does it mean that Jesus came not to abolish the law but to fulfill it?

Look at Matthew 5:17-20 and 22:37-40. How does Jesus keep the law, complete it, and bring it to its goal?

How does Matthew present the death and resurrection of Jesus as the climax of Israel's story?

Consider the Last Supper and the new covenant, the cry from Psalm 22, the torn veil, the centurion, and the Great Commission.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for Jesus, the Christ, the Son of the living God.

Tell him what you have seen in the King through Matthew.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

DAY 602 · WEEK 86

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 15 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Matthew 28:19-20 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age."

MATTHEW 28:19-20

REST

Meditation

These are the last words of Matthew's Gospel, spoken by the risen Lord. They sum up what the church exists to do and the promise that makes it possible.

"Go therefore." The "therefore" connects to the claim in the previous verse: all authority belongs to Jesus. Because he is Lord of all, we go. The mission rests on his authority and not on our ability.

"And make disciples of all nations." The main command is to make disciples, followers and learners of Jesus. "Go," "baptize," and "teach" all serve this. And it is for all nations, every people and language. The blessing promised to Abraham now goes out to the world.

“Baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit.” New disciples are brought into the community of the triune God and his people.

“Teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you.” Discipleship is about obedience and not just information. It takes time, and it includes the whole of Jesus’ teaching, including the Sermon on the Mount.

“And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age.” The promise is the secret to all of it. We are not sent alone. The one with all authority is with us in every place and every year until he comes. “Behold” tells us to look at this and take courage.

You may not be going to another country, but you are called to make disciples where you are: at home, work, school, and church. Say this verse as a commission and as a comfort.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you walked through the last days of Jesus’ ministry in Matthew. You saw him teach about marriage, wealth, and servant leadership, and give his life as a ransom for many. You watched the king enter Jerusalem on a donkey, answer his enemies with parables and wisdom, and give the two great commandments. In the Olivet Discourse, he called you to be ready and faithful until he returns. In Psalm 118, you read the song of the rejected stone. You sat at the Last Supper, heard the words of the new covenant, and watched him pray in Gethsemane. You followed him through the trials, the mockery, and the cross, and you stood at the empty tomb to hear the Great Commission. Two doctrinal days gave you the Trinity and baptism. Together, they show that the King has come, died, and risen, and that he sends his people to the nations with his presence.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Great Commission says to make disciples of all nations. Who is one person in your life that you could invest in as a disciple, or from whom you could learn as a disciple?

Jesus promises, “I am with you always.” In what situation do you most need to believe that promise right now?

Matthew began with Immanuel, “God with us,” and ended with “I am with you always.” How does that frame change the way you read the whole Gospel?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that all authority is his and he is with you always.

Ask him to send you to make disciples where you are.

Tell him who you will begin with.

Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 16 · DAYS 603-633

The New Covenant Inaugurated: Luke

Luke 1-24

The universal scope of redemption. Good news for the poor, the outcast, and all nations.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost."

LUKE 19:10

Praise (113, 116, 117) and trust under pressure (27, 28, 31, 41, 55) beside Luke.

UNIT 16

In this unit

WEEK 87

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604	Luke 2:1-52	*Reading*
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610	Psalm 116	*Psalm*
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612	Luke 7:1-8:21	*Reading*
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620	Luke 13:22-15:32	*Reading*
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622	Luke 18:1-19:27	*Reading*
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624	Luke 19:28-21:38	*Reading*

625	Psalm 31:19-24	*Psalm*
626	Psalm 41	*Psalm*
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628	Luke 22:1-46	*Reading*
629	Luke 22:47-23:25	*Reading*
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WEEK 91

631	Luke 23:26-56	*Reading*
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633	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 603 · WEEK 87

Luke 1:1-80

The promise; the Magnificat; the Benedictus

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 1:1-80. Luke begins with a careful preface, then tells of two miraculous births: John to an old priest and his wife, and Jesus to a young virgin. Read Mary's song (1:46-55) and Zechariah's song (1:68-79) aloud, slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Luke was a physician and a traveling companion of Paul. He was not an eyewitness, and he says so. He investigated everything carefully and wrote an orderly account for a man named Theophilus, so that he might know the certainty of what he had been taught. Luke also wrote the book of Acts, and together the two books make up about a quarter of the New Testament. Luke is especially interested in the Holy Spirit, in prayer, in women, in the poor and outcast, and in good news that reaches the Gentiles. The Gospel opens in the temple in Jerusalem, in the dusty hill country, and in a small town of Galilee, and it begins with songs.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It seemed good to me also, having followed all things closely for some time past, to write an orderly account for you, most excellent Theophilus" (1:3).
2. "And he will be filled with the Holy Spirit, even from his mother's womb" (1:15).
3. "The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you; therefore the child to be born will be called holy, the Son of God" (1:35).
4. "For nothing will be impossible with God" (1:37).
5. "Behold, I am the servant of the Lord; let it be to me according to your word" (1:38).
6. "My soul magnifies the Lord, and my spirit rejoices in God my Savior" (1:46-47).

7. “He has brought down the mighty from their thrones and exalted those of humble estate; he has filled the hungry with good things, and the rich he has sent away empty” (1:52-53).

8. “Blessed be the Lord God of Israel, for he has visited and redeemed his people” (1:68).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Luke tells us at the outset what kind of book this is. It is history, researched and arranged with care. The faith is not built on rumor. It is built on events that happened, which witnesses saw and Luke investigated.

The first scene is in the temple. An old priest named Zechariah is told that his barren wife Elizabeth will bear a son who will go before the Lord “in the spirit and power of Elijah,” to turn hearts and prepare a people. Zechariah doubts and is made silent. The Gospel begins where the Old Testament ended, with Malachi’s promise of Elijah, and with silence broken.

Then the angel comes to Mary, a young woman in Nazareth, and Luke gives us one of the great statements of the incarnation. The Holy Spirit will come upon her, and the child will be the Son of God. Mary’s response is a model of faith: “Let it be to me according to your word.” She does not understand how, but she trusts.

Mary visits Elizabeth, and the unborn John leaps. Then Mary sings the Magnificat, which is built from the songs of the Old Testament, especially Hannah’s. It is a song about reversal. God lifts up the lowly, feeds the hungry, and sends the rich away empty. It is also a song about promise kept: God has helped his servant Israel, “as he spoke to our fathers, to Abraham and to his offspring forever.” The salvation Mary sings about is both spiritual and concrete, and it will turn the world’s order upside down.

The chapter ends with Zechariah’s song, the Benedictus. His tongue is loosed, and he is filled with the Spirit and praises God for visiting and redeeming his people, for raising up a horn of salvation in the house of David, and for remembering his holy covenant. He closes with the image of the sunrise from on high, giving light to those in darkness and guiding feet into the way of peace. A new day is dawning.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 18:14 asked, “Is anything too hard for the LORD?” and Luke 1:37 answers it. 1 Samuel 2:1-10 is Hannah’s song, which stands behind Mary’s. Malachi 4:5-6 promised Elijah, and Luke 1:17 shows John fulfilling it. 2 Samuel 7:12-16 is the promise to David that Gabriel

echoes in 1:32-33. Isaiah 7:14 and 9:6-7 are in the background. John 1:14 says the Word became flesh. Galatians 4:4 says God sent forth his Son, born of woman.

STEP 6

Application

Read the Magnificat aloud. Which line speaks to you most, and why?

Think of a promise from God that seems impossible. Pray Mary's answer: "Let it be to me according to your word."

Notice how many people in this chapter are ordinary and humble. Thank God that he works through those the world overlooks.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Say to God, "Let it be to me according to your word," and tell him what that means for you.
- Thank him for keeping his promises to Abraham and David.
- Praise him, as Mary did, in your own words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 87

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

DAY 604 · WEEK 87

Luke 2:1-52

The birth; the shepherds; Simeon and Anna; the boy Jesus

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 2:1-52. Luke gives the birth of Jesus with historical care and quiet wonder. Notice who hears the news first, and notice the last verse of the chapter.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Luke sets the birth of Jesus in the larger world: Caesar Augustus, a census, Quirinius governing Syria. The emperor is moving millions of people with a decree, yet the real King is being born in a stable to a peasant couple. Luke wants us to see the contrast between earthly power and heavenly power. Bethlehem is the city of David, so the birth fulfills the promise that the Messiah would come from David's line.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And she gave birth to her firstborn son and wrapped him in swaddling cloths and laid him in a manger, because there was no place for them in the inn" (2:7).
2. "And in the same region there were shepherds out in the field, keeping watch over their flock by night" (2:8).
3. "Fear not, for behold, I bring you good news of great joy that will be for all the people" (2:10).
4. "For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord" (2:11).
5. "Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace among those with whom he is pleased!" (2:14).
6. "But Mary treasured up all these things, pondering them in her heart" (2:19).

7. “For my eyes have seen your salvation… a light for revelation to the Gentiles, and for glory to your people Israel” (2:30-32).

8. “And Jesus increased in wisdom and in stature and in favor with God and man” (2:52).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The birth is told simply. There is no room for them in the inn, and the Savior is laid in a feeding trough. The Son of God enters the world in poverty and obscurity.

The first announcement is not to the powerful but to shepherds, who were low on the social ladder and often distrusted. An angel appears, and the glory of the Lord shines around them. The news is “good news of great joy that will be for all the people,” and the titles in verse 11 are rich. The child is a Savior, the Christ, and the Lord. A baby in a manger is all three. The shepherds go in haste, find the child as they were told, and return glorifying and praising God. They are the first evangelists.

When the child is brought to the temple, two old people recognize him. Simeon had been promised by the Spirit that he would not die before seeing the Lord’s Christ. He takes the child in his arms and sings: his eyes have seen salvation, prepared in the presence of all peoples, “a light for revelation to the Gentiles, and for glory to your people Israel.” This is the universal note of Luke. Simeon also tells Mary that a sword will pierce her own soul, because the child will cause the rising and falling of many and be opposed. Joy and sorrow are linked from the start. Anna, an elderly prophetess who never left the temple, gives thanks and tells everyone who was waiting for the redemption of Jerusalem.

The chapter ends with the twelve-year-old Jesus in the temple, listening to teachers and asking questions. When his parents find him, he says, “Did you not know that I must be in my Father’s house?” Already he knows who his Father is. And yet he goes home and is subject to them. The Son of God grows up, with all the ordinary stages of human life.

STEP 5

Connection

Micah 5:2 names Bethlehem as the place of the ruler’s birth. Isaiah 9:6 says to us a child is born. Isaiah 49:6 speaks of a light for the nations. Luke 2:34-35 points ahead to the cross. Philippians 2:6-8 describes the Son who emptied himself and took the form of a servant. 2 Corinthians 8:9 says that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor. Hebrews 2:14 says he shared in our flesh and blood.

STEP 6

Application

Take time to listen to the angels' words as if they were spoken to you: "Fear not… unto you is born this day a Savior."

Ponder, like Mary, one thing from this week's reading. Hold it in your heart and pray over it.

Be like the shepherds and tell someone the good news of great joy this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for sending his Son in humility.

Tell him what it is like to hear that the news of his birth is for all people.

Ask him to teach you to treasure it, as Mary did.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 87

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

DAY 605 · WEEK 87

Luke 3:1-4:13

John; baptism; genealogy; the temptation

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 3:1-4:13. John preaches, Jesus is baptized and prays, a genealogy runs back to Adam, and the devil tests him in the wilderness. Compare this with Matthew's accounts, and notice what Luke adds.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Luke again places the story in history, naming Tiberius, Pilate, Herod, and the high priests. Into that world, the word of God comes to John in the wilderness. Luke's account of John is fuller in some ways than Matthew's, with specific advice for the crowds, tax collectors, and soldiers. His genealogy of Jesus runs backward to Adam rather than forward from Abraham, which fits Luke's concern for all people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The word of God came to John the son of Zechariah in the wilderness" (3:2).
2. "And all flesh shall see the salvation of God" (3:6).
3. "Bear fruits in keeping with repentance" (3:8).
4. "Whoever has two tunics is to share with him who has none, and whoever has food is to do likewise" (3:11).
5. "Now when all the people were baptized, and when Jesus also had been baptized and was praying, the heavens were opened" (3:21).
6. "The son of Adam, the son of God" (3:38).
7. "And Jesus, full of the Holy Spirit, returned from the Jordan and was led by the Spirit in the wilderness" (4:1).

8 “And when the devil had ended every temptation, he departed from him until an opportune time” (4:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Luke 3:6 quotes Isaiah 40 and goes a step further than the other Gospels, ending with “all flesh shall see the salvation of God.” This is Luke’s theme. John’s message is practical. When the crowds ask what to do, he tells them to share. Tax collectors are told to collect no more than they are authorized. Soldiers are to stop extorting. Repentance has a concrete shape: generosity and honesty.

At the baptism, Luke alone notes that Jesus was praying. This is the first of many times in Luke that prayer precedes a decisive moment in Jesus’ life. While he prays, the Spirit descends in bodily form and the Father speaks: “You are my beloved Son; with you I am well pleased.” The Trinity is present: the Father speaks, the Son prays, and the Spirit descends.

The genealogy that follows runs from Jesus back through David, Abraham, Noah, and finally to Adam, “the son of God.” Jesus is the second Adam, and his story is humanity’s story. Where Adam failed in a garden, he will succeed in a wilderness.

In the temptation, Luke notes that Jesus was full of the Holy Spirit and led by the Spirit. He is hungry after forty days. The devil first tempts him to turn stones into bread, then offers him all the kingdoms of the world, and finally takes him to the pinnacle of the temple and quotes Scripture to him. Jesus answers each time with a verse from Deuteronomy. Luke reverses the order of the second and third temptations from Matthew, ending in Jerusalem, where the story will end. The devil departs “until an opportune time,” a hint that the real battle is still ahead.

The Son of God does not use his power to serve himself. He relies on the word of God and the Spirit, as we must.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 40:3-5 is the passage John fulfills. Genesis 3 is the first temptation, and Romans 5:12-19 contrasts Adam and Christ. 1 Corinthians 15:45 calls Christ the last Adam. Hebrews 2:18 says that because he himself has suffered when tempted, he is able to help those who are being tempted. Luke 22:3 shows the devil’s return at the “opportune time,” when Satan enters Judas. Ephesians 6:17 describes the sword of the Spirit.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what fruit in keeping with repentance would look like for you this week. Be as practical as John was.

When temptation comes, answer it with Scripture, as Jesus did. Choose a verse to carry.

Pray before big decisions, as Jesus did at his baptism.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus, the last Adam, for resisting where the first fell.

Ask him to fill you with his Spirit.

Tell him where you are being tempted.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 87

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

DAY 606 · WEEK 87

Luke 4:14-5:39

Nazareth; first disciples; controversies

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 4:14-5:39. Jesus preaches in Nazareth, is rejected, begins to heal and call disciples, and meets his first controversies. Read 4:18-21 slowly. It is the mission statement of the whole Gospel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus returns to Galilee in the power of the Spirit. He goes to the synagogue in Nazareth, his hometown, as was his custom, and he is handed the scroll of Isaiah. The reading he chooses is from Isaiah 61, which describes the anointed one who will bring good news to the poor. What he says next, and how the people respond, sets the pattern for his ministry: great grace and great opposition.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor" (4:18).
2. "He has sent me to proclaim liberty to the captives and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty those who are oppressed" (4:18).
3. "Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing" (4:21).
4. "Truly, I say to you, no prophet is acceptable in his hometown" (4:24).
5. "But he would withdraw to desolate places and pray" (5:16).
6. "Depart from me, for I am a sinful man, O Lord" (5:8).
7. "Do not be afraid; from now on you will be catching men" (5:10).
8. "I have not come to call the righteous but sinners to repentance" (5:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Nazareth, Jesus reads the words of Isaiah and sits down, as a teacher does. Every eye is fastened on him. “Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing.” That is a stunning claim. He is the anointed one of Isaiah 61: the Spirit is upon him, and he brings good news to the poor, freedom to captives, sight to the blind, and release to the oppressed. The “year of the Lord’s favor” is the jubilee, the great year of release.

The people at first marvel at his gracious words. But then he reminds them that God sent Elijah to a widow in Sidon and Elisha to heal Naaman the Syrian, both Gentiles, while Israel’s own needy were passed over. The hometown crowd erupts in fury and tries to throw him off a cliff. The pattern is set. The good news will go to outsiders, and many insiders will reject it. Jesus passes through the midst of them and goes away.

In Capernaum, he teaches with authority, casts out a demon, heals Peter’s mother-in-law, and heals many at sundown. Luke notes that he withdraws to pray in desolate places. Even when crowds clamor for him, he keeps to his mission: “I must preach the good news of the kingdom of God to the other towns also; for I was sent for this purpose.”

The miraculous catch of fish leads to Peter’s confession. Seeing the power of Jesus, Peter does not rejoice but falls at his knees, saying, “Depart from me, for I am a sinful man.” The presence of holiness exposes sin. Jesus does not depart. He says, “Do not be afraid,” and calls Peter to follow. Peter, James, and John leave everything.

Then come the first controversies: Jesus forgives and heals a paralyzed man, calls Levi the tax collector, and eats with sinners. The Pharisees grumble, and Jesus answers: “Those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick.” He then speaks of new wine in new wineskins. The new covenant cannot be poured into the old forms.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 61:1-2 and 58:6 stand behind Jesus’ reading. Leviticus 25 describes the year of jubilee. 1 Kings 17:8-16 and 2 Kings 5 are the Old Testament stories Jesus cites. Isaiah 6:5 shows the prophet’s cry, “Woe is me!” before the holy God. Mark 2:17 has the parallel on the physician. 2 Corinthians 5:17 says that if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. John 1:11 says he came to his own, and his own people did not receive him.

STEP 6

Application

Read Isaiah 61:1-2 slowly and ask where Jesus has done this in your life.

Notice Jesus' habit of slipping away to pray. Plan a regular time and place for it.

Like Peter, bring your sinfulness to Jesus without hiding it, and hear him say, "Do not be afraid."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for bringing good news to the poor, liberty to captives, and sight to the blind.

Tell him what you need him to set free in you.

Ask him to teach you to follow.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 87

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

DAY 607 · WEEK 87

Luke 6:1-49

Sabbath disputes; the Twelve; the Sermon on the Plain

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 49 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 6:1-49. Sabbath disputes, the choosing of the Twelve after a night of prayer, and the Sermon on the Plain. Compare it with the Sermon on the Mount from Matthew 5 to 7.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Opposition from the religious leaders grows over the Sabbath. Then Jesus spends a night in prayer on the mountain, chooses twelve apostles, and comes down to a level place to teach a great crowd. The Sermon on the Plain is shorter than Matthew's version and focused on a few things: blessings and woes, love for enemies, mercy, and obedience. It is likely the same teaching given on another occasion, or a summary.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The Son of Man is lord of the Sabbath" (6:5).
2. "In these days he went out to the mountain to pray, and all night he continued in prayer to God" (6:12).
3. "Blessed are you who are poor, for yours is the kingdom of God" (6:20).
4. "But woe to you who are rich, for you have received your consolation" (6:24).
5. "But I say to you who hear, Love your enemies, do good to those who hate you" (6:27).
6. "Be merciful, even as your Father is merciful" (6:36).
7. "Why do you call me Lord, Lord, and not do what I tell you?" (6:46).
8. "But the one who hears and does not do is like a man who built a house on the ground without a foundation" (6:49).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Sabbath conflicts show what is at stake. The disciples pluck grain, and Jesus defends them, citing David, and declares himself lord of the Sabbath. On another Sabbath, he heals a man's withered hand, and asks, "Is it lawful on the Sabbath to do good or to do harm, to save life or to destroy it?" The Pharisees are filled with fury.

Then comes the night of prayer. Before choosing the Twelve, Jesus spends the whole night in prayer. A major decision is preceded by deep communion with the Father. He names twelve, including Judas Iscariot, "who became a traitor." The Twelve are the foundation of the renewed Israel.

On the plain, with a great crowd, he gives the Beatitudes with a difference. Luke records four blessings and four woes. "Blessed are you who are poor... hungry... weep... hated." And "woe to you who are rich... full... laugh... spoken well of." These are not general wishes. Jesus speaks to his disciples, and he puts the reversal clearly: those who look secure now may be empty later, and those who suffer for him will be rewarded.

The heart of the sermon is love for enemies. "Love your enemies, do good to those who hate you, bless those who curse you, pray for those who abuse you." This is not just a rule for sentiment but for action: give, lend, and expect nothing back. The standard is the character of God himself: "Be merciful, even as your Father is merciful." The Father is kind even to the ungrateful and the evil.

Then come warnings about judging, the log in the eye, and a tree known by its fruit. The sermon ends with the two builders. The one who hears and does is like the one who dug deep and laid the foundation on rock. The difference is obedience, and the question is pointed: "Why do you call me Lord, Lord, and not do what I tell you?"

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 5 to 7 is the longer Sermon on the Mount, and you read it in Unit 15. Psalm 1 is the background to the two ways. 1 Samuel 21:1-6 is the story of David's eating the bread. Romans 12:14-21 repeats Jesus' teaching on enemies. 1 Peter 2:21-23 says Christ left us an example. James 1:22 says to be doers of the word. Ephesians 4:32 says to forgive as God in Christ forgave you.

STEP 6

Application

Pray through the night, or at least for an hour, before a significant decision.

Choose one enemy or difficult person and do something good for them this week, without expecting anything back.

Ask the Lord's own question of yourself: do I call him Lord and do what he says?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for being Lord of the Sabbath.

Thank him for praying all night before choosing his apostles.

Ask him to help you do what he says, not only hear.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 87

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

DAY 608 · WEEK 87

Psalm 113

He raises the poor from the dust, the Magnificat's psalm

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 113. This is the first psalm in the Hallel (Psalms 113 to 118). It praises the God who raises the poor from the dust, and it echoes Hannah's song and Mary's song. Read it beside the Magnificat.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 113 opens a group of six psalms sung at Passover and other great feasts. It is short and structured as three stanzas: God's name is to be praised, God is high above all nations, and yet he stoops to lift the needy. It stands behind Hannah's song in 1 Samuel 2 and Mary's song in Luke 1. Reading it just after Luke 1 and 2 shows where Mary found her words.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Praise, O servants of the LORD, praise the name of the LORD!" (v. 1).
2. "Blessed be the name of the LORD from this time forth and forevermore!" (v. 2).
3. "From the rising of the sun to its setting, the name of the LORD is to be praised!" (v. 3).
4. "The LORD is high above all nations, and his glory above the heavens!" (v. 4).
5. "Who is like the LORD our God, who is seated on high" (v. 5).
6. "Who looks far down on the heavens and the earth?" (v. 6).
7. "He raises the poor from the dust and lifts the needy from the ash heap" (v. 7).
8. "He gives the barren woman a home, making her the joyous mother of children" (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with praise and its scope grows wider with each verse. First the servants of the LORD, then all time ("from this time forth and forevermore"), then all space ("from the rising of the sun to its setting"). The name of the LORD is to be praised everywhere and always.

Then the question: "Who is like the LORD our God?" He is seated on high, above all nations and above the heavens. In the ancient world, the great gods were high and distant. But here is the surprise. This God "looks far down on the heavens and the earth." He is so high that even the heavens are far below him, and yet he looks down and sees the lowly.

What does he do? He raises the poor from the dust. He lifts the needy from the ash heap and seats them with princes, even the princes of his people. And he gives the barren woman a home and a family. This is the pattern of the Bible's story: Sarah, Rebekah, Rachel, Hannah, and Elizabeth. Again and again the barren woman receives a child, and God's purposes advance through those who seemed least likely.

Now read Luke 1 again. Mary sings, "He has brought down the mighty from their thrones and exalted those of humble estate." She draws on this psalm and on Hannah's song. Elizabeth, barren, has a son in her old age. Mary herself is of humble estate, and she carries the Son of God. The one who raises the poor from the dust has come down in person. The incarnation is the greatest instance of the psalm: the God who is high above all stoops lower than anyone could expect, to a manger and a cross, and lifts people up.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Samuel 2:1-10 is Hannah's song, and Luke 1:46-55 is Mary's. Isaiah 57:15 says God dwells in the high and holy place and also with the contrite and lowly. Philippians 2:5-11 describes Christ's descent and exaltation. Ephesians 2:4-6 says God raised us up with Christ and seated us with him in the heavenly places. James 4:6 says God gives grace to the humble. Matthew 26:30 says that after the Last Supper they sang a hymn, likely the Hallel.

STEP 6

Application

Praise God today from the "rising of the sun to its setting." Make it a thread through your day.

Think of someone overlooked or lowly. Ask how you might lift them up.

Thank God that he lifted you from the dust through Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God for raising the poor from the dust.

Tell him what he has lifted you from.

Bless his name now and forevermore.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 87

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

DAY 609 · WEEK 87

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Luke 2:11 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."

LUKE 2:11

REST

Meditation

An angel says these words to shepherds in the dark, on a hillside outside Bethlehem. It is the message at the center of the Christmas story and of the Gospel.

"For unto you." The news is personal. The angel does not say, "For the world in general." He says, "For you." The first people to hear it were common workers in the fields. The gospel comes to people where they are, and it is addressed to each of us.

"Is born this day." The word "today" is one of Luke's favorites. Salvation is not only a future hope. It has arrived in time and space, on a particular day, in a real town. God has acted in history.

"In the city of David." The Savior comes in the line of the great king. Every promise about David's throne is being fulfilled in this child.

“A Savior.” The word means rescuer. He is born not just to teach or to inspire but to save. Matthew told us he would save his people from their sins. Luke says that he is a Savior for “all the people.”

“Who is Christ the Lord.” Christ means the anointed king. Lord means the one who rules, and it is the word the Greek Old Testament used for God himself. The baby in the manger is God’s anointed king and God himself.

When you feel that the gospel is too big or too distant, say this verse. It was spoken first to shepherds, and it is for you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the Gospel of Luke. You read Luke’s careful preface, the promise of two births, and the songs of Mary and Zechariah, which celebrate God’s keeping of every promise. You saw the Savior born in a manger and heard the angels announce good news to shepherds. You watched Simeon and Anna recognize him in the temple. You followed John’s call to repentance, Jesus’ baptism and temptation, and his first sermon in Nazareth, where he read Isaiah and said, “Today this Scripture has been fulfilled.” You saw him call sinners, eat with outcasts, and spend a whole night in prayer before choosing the Twelve. The Sermon on the Plain called you to love your enemies and build on the rock. Psalm 113 gave you the words behind the Magnificat: the God who is high above all stoops to raise the poor from the dust.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Luke records that the angels’ first announcement was to shepherds. What does that tell you about the kind of people the gospel is for, and how might it change who you notice this week?

Jesus read Isaiah 61 in Nazareth and said, “Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing.” How does Jesus fulfill the good news for the poor, the captives, and the blind?

Mary said, “Let it be to me according to your word.” Where do you most need to say that to God right now?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that to us a Savior is born.

Thank him that the good news is for all people.

Let yourself rest in it.

DAY 610 · WEEK 88

Psalm 116

I love the LORD, because he has heard my voice

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 19 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 116. This is a song of thanks from someone who was near death and was saved. It is part of the Hallel, sung at Passover. Read it aloud as a personal testimony.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 116 is a thanksgiving psalm. The singer has cried out in deep trouble and God has answered, and now he comes to the congregation to keep his vows. The psalm is anonymous, but it is easy to imagine David or Hezekiah behind it. Because it belongs to the Hallel, Jesus and his disciples almost certainly sang it on the night before he died, a few hours before Gethsemane.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I love the LORD, because he has heard my voice and my pleas for mercy" (v. 1).
2. "Because he inclined his ear to me, therefore I will call on him as long as I live" (v. 2).
3. "The snares of death encompassed me; the pangs of Sheol laid hold on me; I suffered distress and anguish" (v. 3).
4. "Gracious is the LORD, and righteous; our God is merciful" (v. 5).
5. "The LORD preserves the simple; when I was brought low, he saved me" (v. 6).
6. "For you have delivered my soul from death, my eyes from tears, my feet from stumbling" (v. 8).
7. "What shall I render to the LORD for all his benefits to me?" (v. 12).
8. "Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of his saints" (v. 15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with love: “I love the LORD.” The reason is not a general feeling but a specific answer. He heard my voice. The God of the universe bent down his ear to a person in need. The psalmist concludes that he will call on God for as long as he lives.

Then he tells his story. Death had wrapped around him like a snare. Distress and anguish found him. In that darkness he called, “O LORD, I pray, deliver my soul!” and the LORD answered. The character of the God who answers is given in verse 5: gracious, righteous, and merciful. These three words belong together. His grace is never at odds with his justice.

He says he was “brought low,” and the LORD saved him. Now he can rest: “Return, O my soul, to your rest, for the LORD has dealt bountifully with you.” Deliverance from death, tears, and stumbling is the work of God alone.

Then comes one of the great questions of the Psalter: “What shall I render to the LORD for all his benefits to me?” The answer is not a payment, since no one can repay God. It is worship and trust: “I will lift up the cup of salvation and call on the name of the LORD.” He will pay his vows in the presence of all the people.

Verse 15 is for the grieving: “Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of his saints.” Death is not meaningless to God. Every believer who dies is watched over with care.

Read this psalm beside the Last Supper. Jesus lifted a cup that night, and the psalm was in his mouth. He would soon drink a cup of suffering so that we might receive the cup of salvation. The cry of the psalmist became the cry of Jesus, and the deliverance he sang about was won in his death and resurrection.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 18:4-6 describes similar cords of death. Matthew 26:30 and Mark 14:26 say they sang a hymn before going out. Luke 22:17-20 describes the cup at the Supper. 1 Corinthians 10:16 speaks of the cup of blessing. Romans 12:1 offers the answer to “What shall I render?” Hebrews 2:14-15 says Christ delivered those enslaved by fear of death. Revelation 14:13 speaks of those who die in the Lord.

STEP 6

Application

Tell the story of a time God answered you. Write it down or tell it to someone.

Answer verse 12 for yourself. What will you render to the LORD this week? Make it concrete.

If you have lost a believer, rest in verse 15. Their death is precious to the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God that you love him and why.
- Thank him for delivering you from death and tears.
- Ask him what you can render to him for all his benefits.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 88

"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me."

LUKE 9:23

DAY 611 · WEEK 88

Psalm 117

Praise the LORD, all nations, the shortest psalm; widest vision

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 2 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 117. It has only two verses. Read it three times, slowly, once for each phrase of the call, and notice how much is packed into so few words.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 117 is the shortest chapter in the Bible and the middle chapter of the Bible's chapters, by number. It is part of the Hallel, sung at the feasts. In two verses it calls the whole world to praise the God of Israel, and gives the reason. Paul quotes it in Romans 15 to show that the Gentiles were always meant to glorify God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD" (v. 1).
2. "all nations" (v. 1).
3. "Extol him" (v. 1).
4. "all peoples" (v. 1).
5. "great is his steadfast love" (v. 2).
6. "toward us" (v. 2).
7. "the faithfulness of the LORD" (v. 2).
8. "endures forever" (v. 2).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is short, but it is wide. The call is not to Israel only but to “all nations” and “all peoples.” Under the old covenant, God’s saving work was centered on one nation. But from the beginning, the aim was the world. God promised Abraham that in him all the families of the earth would be blessed. The psalmists often sing of a day when the nations will bow. Psalm 117 states it as a command: praise the LORD, all of you.

Notice the reason: “For great is his steadfast love toward us.” The word “us” is Israel, the people who knew God’s covenant love. The nations are called to praise him because of what he has done for his people. When the nations see the LORD’s love to Israel, they are drawn to worship. And the Gentiles who come in are included in the “us” by faith.

The two characteristics that the psalm names are the two that run through the whole Old Testament: steadfast love and faithfulness. They were revealed to Moses on Sinai (“abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness”) and they are the foundation of the covenant. God does not just love; he keeps his word. His faithfulness “endures forever.”

This is the Bible in miniature: the LORD’s love for his people, his faithfulness through time, and his purpose for the world. Luke’s Gospel carries the same note. Simeon sang of a light for the Gentiles. John the Baptist quoted Isaiah, “All flesh shall see the salvation of God.” Jesus will praise the faith of a Roman centurion. The psalm that told the nations to sing is being fulfilled in the church today, as people from every tribe and language come to Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 12:3 promised blessing to all the families of the earth. Exodus 34:6 states the LORD’s character. Psalm 67 prays that all the nations praise him. Isaiah 49:6 speaks of salvation to the end of the earth. Luke 2:32 echoes it. Romans 15:11 quotes this psalm. Revelation 7:9 pictures a great multitude from every nation, praising God.

STEP 6

Application

Read the psalm aloud in a different voice each time: quietly, with joy, and as a shout.

Pray for one nation or people group by name today, that they would praise the LORD.

Memorize the two verses. They are the shortest way to remember what God’s love and faithfulness mean.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God with all the nations in your own words.

Thank him for his great steadfast love toward us.

Pray for the nations to know him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 88

"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me."

LUKE 9:23

DAY 612 · WEEK 88

Luke 7:1-8:21

The centurion; the widow's son; the sinful woman; the Sower

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 7:1-8:21. A Gentile's faith, a widow's son, a sinful woman, and the parable of the sower. Notice who Jesus honors, and who he rebukes.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the Sermon on the Plain, Jesus enters Capernaum and then Nain, then dines with a Pharisee, then tells parables by the lake. Luke gathers stories that show Jesus' compassion for the outsider: a Roman soldier, a widow, a woman with a bad reputation. These are the people the religious leaders overlooked. Jesus will respond to John the Baptist's doubts by pointing to what he is doing.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I tell you, not even in Israel have I found such faith" (7:9).
2. "And when the Lord saw her, he had compassion on her and said to her, Do not weep" (7:13).
3. "The blind receive their sight, the lame walk, lepers are cleansed, and the deaf hear, the dead are raised up, the poor have good news preached to them" (7:22).
4. "But he who is forgiven little, loves little" (7:47).
5. "Your faith has saved you; go in peace" (7:50).
6. "The seed is the word of God" (8:11).
7. "And as for that in the good soil, they are those who, hearing the word, hold it fast in an honest and good heart, and bear fruit with patience" (8:15).
8. "My mother and my brothers are those who hear the word of God and do it" (8:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

A Roman centurion sends friends to ask Jesus to heal his servant. He says he is not worthy to have Jesus come under his roof, and that Jesus need only say the word. Jesus marvels, and says he has not found such faith in Israel. A pagan soldier understood authority better than the religious insiders. Faith is believing that Jesus' word is enough.

At Nain, Jesus meets a funeral procession. A widow's only son is dead. Luke notes simply that when the Lord saw her, he had compassion. He touches the bier, speaks, and the young man sits up. Jesus gives him back to his mother. The crowd says, "God has visited his people!" That is the right conclusion.

John the Baptist, now in prison, sends disciples to ask whether Jesus is the one. Jesus does not give a direct yes. He tells them to report what they see and hear: the blind see, the lame walk, the dead are raised, the poor hear good news. These are the signs of Isaiah's promised age.

In Simon the Pharisee's house, an uninvited woman, known as a sinner, weeps on Jesus' feet, wipes them with her hair, and anoints them. Simon is scandalized. Jesus tells a story of two debtors, one forgiven a large debt and one a small debt. The one forgiven more loves more. Then he turns to the woman and says, "Your sins are forgiven." Her love was the result of forgiveness, not the cause. Simon, who thought he needed little, loved little.

The parable of the sower closes the section. The seed is the word, and the soils are hearts. Some hearts are hard, some shallow, some choked, and some good. The good soil hears, holds fast, and bears fruit with patience. Jesus' real family are not those with the right blood but those who hear and do the word of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 35:5-6 and 61:1 stand behind Jesus' answer to John. 1 Kings 17:17-24 is Elijah raising the widow's son, the pattern Jesus fulfills. Psalm 103:3 praises the God who forgives all your iniquity. Ephesians 2:8 says we are saved by grace through faith. Hebrews 11:6 says without faith it is impossible to please God. Romans 10:17 says faith comes from hearing. James 1:22 repeats the call to be doers of the word.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself: which soil is closest to my heart right now? What would it take to be good soil?

Think of the woman who loved much. What has Jesus forgiven you? Let that fuel your love this week.

Be like the centurion and trust Jesus' word without needing to see how.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for his compassion for outsiders and sinners.

Tell him how much you have been forgiven, and let love rise.

Ask him to help you love as one who has been forgiven much.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 88

"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me."

LUKE 9:23

DAY 613 · WEEK 88

Luke 8:22-9:50

The storm; Jairus; Peter's confession; the Transfiguration

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 8:22-9:50. A storm stilled, a girl raised, the Twelve sent out, Peter's confession, the Transfiguration. This section turns on one question: who is Jesus?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus now shows his power over nature, demons, sickness, and death. Then, in chapter 9, the question of his identity moves to the center. Herod wonders who he is, the crowds guess, Peter answers. Right after the confession, Jesus speaks plainly of his coming suffering and the cost of following him. Eight days later, three disciples see his glory on the mountain.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Master, Master, we are perishing!" (8:24).
2. "Where is your faith?" (8:25).
3. "Daughter, your faith has made you well; go in peace" (8:48).
4. "Do not fear; only believe, and she will be well" (8:50).
5. "But who do you say that I am?" Peter answered, "The Christ of God" (9:20).
6. "If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me" (9:23).
7. "This is my Son, my Chosen One; listen to him!" (9:35).
8. "For he who is least among you all is the one who is great" (9:48).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The storm on the lake shows who Jesus is. The disciples, some of them experienced fishermen, cry out that they are perishing. Jesus rebukes the wind and the waves, and there is calm. They ask, “Who then is this, that he commands even winds and water, and they obey him?” The Old Testament says only God does that (Psalm 107:29).

Then he crosses to the Gerasenes and frees a man possessed by many demons. The man, once naked and chained among the tombs, is found sitting at Jesus’ feet, clothed and in his right mind. When the people ask Jesus to leave, he tells the man to go home and declare how much God has done for him. The first missionary to the Gentiles was a former demoniac.

Jairus’s daughter and the woman with the flow of blood are woven together. The woman has been unclean and suffering for twelve years, and she touches the edge of his garment. Jesus stops, and calls her “Daughter.” A message comes that Jairus’s daughter has died. Jesus says, “Do not fear; only believe.” He takes her hand and says, “Child, arise,” and she does. Jesus is Lord over sickness and death.

The Twelve are sent out with power and authority. Herod hears and is perplexed. Jesus feeds the five thousand, and then asks the key question. The crowds say John, Elijah, or one of the prophets. Peter says, “The Christ of God.” Jesus warns them not to tell anyone yet, and speaks of suffering, rejection, death, and resurrection. Then he tells all who would follow that they must take up their cross daily. To follow the Christ is to follow the way of the cross.

Eight days later, on the mountain, Jesus is transfigured. Moses and Elijah speak with him about his “departure,” literally his exodus, which he will accomplish at Jerusalem. The voice from the cloud says, “This is my Son, my Chosen One; listen to him!” Then the disciples argue about who is greatest, and Jesus sets a child beside him. In the kingdom, greatness is humility.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 107:23-30 describes the sea stilled by the LORD. Isaiah 53 is the suffering servant behind Jesus’ words about his death. Exodus 24 and 34 recall Moses on the mountain. Deuteronomy 18:15 told Israel to listen to the coming prophet. Matthew 16:13-28 and Mark 8:27-9:1 are the parallels. Romans 6:3-5 says we are united with Christ in his death and resurrection. Galatians 2:20 says, “I have been crucified with Christ.”

STEP 6

Application

Name the storm you are in. Bring it to Jesus as the disciples did, and hear him ask, “Where is your faith?”

Answer Jesus’ own question in your own words: “Who do you say that I am?”

Take up your cross daily. What does that mean today for your habits, your time, and your pride?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Say with Peter who Jesus is.
- Tell him what storm you are facing.
- Ask him to teach you to listen to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 88

“If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me.”

LUKE 9:23

DAY 614 · WEEK 88

Luke 9:51-11:13

The Good Samaritan; Mary and Martha; teaching on prayer

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 91 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 9:51-11:13. The journey to Jerusalem begins, and with it the great central section of Luke. Notice the parable of the Good Samaritan, Mary and Martha, and the Lord's Prayer.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Luke 9:51 is the hinge of the Gospel: "When the days drew near for him to be taken up, he set his face to go to Jerusalem." From here to chapter 19, most of the material is on the road. Much of it is found only in Luke, including the Good Samaritan, Mary and Martha, and many of the parables. The journey is about discipleship, mercy, and prayer, with the cross ahead.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When the days drew near for him to be taken up, he set his face to go to Jerusalem" (9:51).
2. "Foxes have holes, and birds of the air have nests, but the Son of Man has nowhere to lay his head" (9:58).
3. "The harvest is plentiful, but the laborers are few" (10:2).
4. "You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength and with all your mind, and your neighbor as yourself" (10:27).
5. "But a Samaritan, as he journeyed, came to where he was, and when he saw him, he had compassion" (10:33).
6. "Mary has chosen the good portion, which will not be taken away from her" (10:42).
7. "Lord, teach us to pray" (11:1).

8 “How much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him!” (11:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus sets his face toward Jerusalem. A Samaritan village will not receive him, and James and John want to call down fire. Jesus rebukes them. The way of Jesus is not vengeance. Would-be followers are warned of the cost: no home, no looking back.

Seventy-two others are sent ahead, two by two, with a message of peace and the kingdom. They come back rejoicing, but Jesus says, “Do not rejoice that the spirits are subject to you, but rejoice that your names are written in heaven.” Salvation is a greater joy than power.

A lawyer asks what he must do to inherit eternal life, and Jesus asks what the Law says. The answer is to love God and neighbor. Wanting to justify himself, the lawyer asks, “Who is my neighbor?” Jesus tells of a man beaten by robbers. A priest and a Levite pass by on the other side. A Samaritan, a despised outsider, stops, binds the wounds, pays for the care. Jesus then turns the question around: not “who is my neighbor,” but “who proved to be a neighbor?” The answer is “The one who showed him mercy.” “You go, and do likewise.” Many Christians also see in the story a picture of Christ himself, the outsider who finds us half dead and pays the price. But the point of the story is mercy toward anyone in need.

At Martha and Mary’s house, Martha is busy and anxious, and Mary sits at Jesus’ feet to listen. Jesus does not scold service, but he says Mary has chosen the better thing. Hearing him comes first.

Then a disciple asks, “Lord, teach us to pray.” Jesus gives a short prayer: Father, hallowed be your name, your kingdom come, give us bread, forgive us, lead us not into temptation. He tells of the friend at midnight and urges persistence: ask, seek, knock. If earthly fathers give good gifts, how much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask. The best answer to prayer is God himself.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 19:18 and Deuteronomy 6:5 are the two commands the lawyer quotes. 2 Kings 1 is Elijah calling down fire, the story James and John echo. Isaiah 50:7 says the Servant set his face like a flint. Matthew 6:9-13 gives the longer version of the Lord’s Prayer. John 4 shows Jesus with a Samaritan woman. Romans 8:15 speaks of the Spirit of adoption by whom we cry, “Abba, Father.” James 2:13 says mercy triumphs over judgment.

STEP 6

Application

Pray the Lord's Prayer slowly today, one line at a time, adding your own words to each.

Ask who the Samaritan is in your life, a person you are tempted to avoid. Show mercy to them.

Sit at Jesus' feet for ten quiet minutes before the busyness begins.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Pray the Lord's Prayer slowly in your own words.

Ask him to teach you to sit at his feet as Mary did.

Ask him to show you who your neighbor is.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 88

"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me."

LUKE 9:23

DAY 615 · WEEK 88

Luke 11:14-13:21

Beelzebul; the rich fool; fear God; the narrow door

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 102 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 11:14-13:21. Conflict with the crowds and the Pharisees, warnings about hypocrisy and greed, the call to be ready, and parables of the kingdom. Read it with the question, “What do I treasure?”

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

On the road to Jerusalem the opposition grows. Some accuse Jesus of casting out demons by Satan. Others demand a sign. Jesus speaks sharply to the Pharisees and lawyers, then turns to the crowds and his disciples with teaching on fear, money, and readiness. These chapters are full of warnings, but also of tenderness: “Fear not, little flock.”

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Blessed rather are those who hear the word of God and keep it!” (11:28).
2. “Take care, and be on your guard against all covetousness, for one’s life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions” (12:15).
3. “Fool! This night your soul is required of you” (12:20).
4. “Fear not, little flock, for it is your Father’s good pleasure to give you the kingdom” (12:32).
5. “For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also” (12:34).
6. “Everyone to whom much was given, of him much will be required” (12:48).
7. “Unless you repent, you will all likewise perish” (13:3).
8. “It is like a grain of mustard seed that a man took and sowed in his garden” (13:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

When Jesus casts out a demon, some say he does it by Beelzebul, and others ask for a sign. Jesus answers that a kingdom divided cannot stand, and that if he casts out demons by the finger of God, then the kingdom of God has come upon them. There is no neutral ground: “Whoever is not with me is against me.” The only sign will be Jonah’s: his death and resurrection. A woman in the crowd calls out a blessing on his mother, and Jesus replies that those who hear and keep the word of God are blessed rather.

At a Pharisee’s meal, Jesus points out that cleaning the outside of the cup while the inside is full of greed is foolish. Six woes follow, to the Pharisees and to the lawyers. These are not words of hatred but of heartbreak for those who keep the outward forms and miss justice and the love of God.

Then he turns to the disciples: beware the leaven of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy. Do not fear those who kill the body. God knows each sparrow, and you are of more value than many sparrows. Whoever acknowledges Christ before others will be acknowledged before the angels of God.

A man asks Jesus to settle an inheritance dispute, and Jesus tells of the rich fool, who stored up barns of grain and planned to relax, and heard, “Fool! This night your soul is required of you.” It is folly to be rich toward self and not rich toward God. He then tells the disciples not to be anxious: the ravens and lilies are cared for. “Fear not, little flock, for it is your Father’s good pleasure to give you the kingdom.” Sell, give, and lay up treasure in heaven.

The rest of the section calls for readiness: be dressed for action, like servants waiting for the master. Much given means much required. Jesus warns that he has come to bring division, and calls for repentance when tragedies occur. The fig tree is given one more year. A woman bent over for eighteen years is healed on the Sabbath, and Jesus calls her a daughter of Abraham. Two short parables close the section: the mustard seed and the leaven. The kingdom starts small and grows beyond expectation.

STEP 5

Connection

Jonah 1 to 3 is the sign Jesus points to. Psalm 84:11 and Matthew 6:19-34 parallel his teaching on treasure and anxiety. Isaiah 5:1-7 is the background to the fig tree. Ecclesiastes 2 describes the vanity of laboring for riches. 1 Timothy 6:6-10 warns about the love of money. Hebrews 3:12-14 warns of the deceitfulness of sin. 1 Peter 5:7 says to cast all your anxieties on him.

STEP 6

Application

Look honestly at where your treasure is. What does your calendar and your bank statement say?

Name an anxiety you carry and give it to the Father who feeds the ravens.

Pray for readiness. If Jesus returned today, what would you want to have finished?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess where you store up for yourself and are not rich toward God.

Thank him for giving you the kingdom.

Ask him to loosen your grip on worry.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 88

"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me."

LUKE 9:23

DAY 616 · WEEK 88

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Luke 9:23 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me."

LUKE 9:23

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this just after Peter's confession and his first prediction of his death. He says it to everyone: "If anyone would come after me." It is an open invitation and a hard one.

"Deny himself." This does not mean to hate yourself or to lose your identity. It means to say no to the self that sits on the throne. To follow Jesus is to stop being the center of your own life.

"Take up his cross." The cross was not a symbol of jewelry in the first century. It was an instrument of public execution, and a person who carried one was walking to his death. Jesus calls his followers to a life of surrender, willing to lose reputation, comfort, and control for his sake.

"Daily." Luke alone adds this word. The cross is not a single dramatic moment but a daily rhythm. Every morning we choose again.

“And follow me.” The road is not an empty road. We follow someone who went before us, and he did not ask us to carry anything he did not carry first. The next verse gives the promise: whoever loses his life for Jesus’ sake will save it.

When you are tempted to protect your comfort, say this verse. The way of the cross is the way of life.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you sang Psalm 116, the thanks of someone saved from death, and Psalm 117, the shortest call to the nations. In Luke 7 and 8 you saw Jesus honor a centurion’s faith, raise a widow’s son, forgive a woman who loved much, and teach about the soils of the heart. You watched him still a storm, free a demoniac, and raise Jairus’s daughter. You heard Peter confess him as the Christ of God and the Father say, “Listen to him.” On the road to Jerusalem you met the Good Samaritan, sat with Mary at Jesus’ feet, and learned to pray. You heard warnings against greed and hypocrisy and the promise to the little flock that the Father is pleased to give the kingdom.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said Mary chose the good portion by sitting at his feet. What would it look like for you to make listening to him the first thing in your day?

In Luke 9:20, Peter confessed Jesus as the Christ of God, and then Jesus spoke of the cross. How does Jesus’ own suffering shape what it means to follow him?

The rich fool stored up treasure for himself and was not rich toward God. What is one way you can be rich toward God this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell Jesus you want to follow him and say what that costs you.

Ask him to teach you to take up your cross daily.

Thank him for going first.

DAY 617 · WEEK 89

Psalm 27

The LORD is my light and my salvation

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 27. It begins with confident trust and ends with patient waiting. Notice how fear and faith sit side by side.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 27 is a psalm of David. The first half (vv. 1-6) is bold, an army encamped around him and his heart unafraid. The second half (vv. 7-14) is a plea, almost trembling, for God to hear. Some think it is two psalms joined, but the effect is true to life: courage in the morning, anxiety in the evening, and both brought to God. It comes in the plan beside Luke's teaching on fear and trust.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD is my light and my salvation; whom shall I fear?" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD is the stronghold of my life; of whom shall I be afraid?" (v. 1).
3. "Though an army encamp against me, my heart shall not fear" (v. 3).
4. "One thing have I asked of the LORD, that will I seek after: that I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life, to gaze upon the beauty of the LORD" (v. 4).
5. "You have said, Seek my face. My heart says to you, Your face, LORD, do I seek" (v. 8).
6. "For my father and my mother have forsaken me, but the LORD will take me in" (v. 10).
7. "I believe that I shall look upon the goodness of the LORD in the land of the living!" (v. 13).
8. "Wait for the LORD; be strong, and let your heart take courage; wait for the LORD!" (v. 14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with three names for God: light, salvation, stronghold. Light shows the way and drives out darkness. Salvation delivers. A stronghold protects. With these three, David asks, “Whom shall I fear?” The questions are not worried. They expect the answer, “No one.”

Then he lists the threats: evildoers who devour, an army, war. And still: “In this I will be confident.” His confidence rests on one desire: “One thing have I asked of the LORD.” Out of all the things he could ask, he asks for God’s presence. He wants to dwell in the house of the LORD, gaze on his beauty, and inquire in his temple. In the day of trouble, God will hide him in his shelter and set him high on a rock. Then he will offer sacrifices with shouts of joy.

At verse 7 the tone shifts. “Hear, O LORD, when I cry aloud; be gracious to me and answer me!” The confident man is also a man in need. He remembers God’s invitation, “Seek my face,” and answers with the same words. He asks God not to hide his face, not to cast him off. Even if his father and mother forsake him, the LORD will take him in.

He asks to be taught God’s way and led on a level path, and he asks to be saved from false witnesses. Then verse 13 is the hinge: “I believe that I shall look upon the goodness of the LORD in the land of the living!” He does not wait for heaven to see God’s goodness. It will come here.

The last verse is an exhortation to himself and to us: wait. Be strong. Take courage. Wait. Waiting is not passive but active trust. In Luke, Jesus said, “Fear not, little flock.” David and Jesus say the same thing. The Lord is light, and there is nothing to fear in his presence.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 23 shares the theme of God’s presence in danger. Psalm 42 and 63 share the thirst for God. Isaiah 60:1 and John 8:12 speak of the light. Matthew 6:33 says to seek first the kingdom. 2 Corinthians 4:6 says God has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ. Romans 8:31 asks, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” Isaiah 40:31 promises renewed strength to those who wait on the LORD.

STEP 6

Application

Say verse 1 aloud, then name the thing you are most afraid of right now and say “Whom shall I fear?”

Write down your “one thing” from verse 4. What do you most want from God?

Choose something to wait on in prayer, and wait with courage.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you fear, and say, “The LORD is my light and my salvation.”

Ask him for the one thing: to dwell with him and see his beauty.

Tell him you wait for him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 89

“Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance.”

LUKE 15:7

DAY 618 · WEEK 89

Psalm 28

Hear the voice of my pleas for mercy

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 28. It begins with a desperate cry and ends with a shout of praise. Notice what changes between verse 5 and verse 6.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 28 is a psalm of David. He is surrounded by wicked people and fears being swept away with them. He cries to the LORD, his rock, and asks for justice. Halfway through there is a change: he hears the answer, and the psalm ends in praise and a prayer for God's people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "To you, O LORD, I call; my rock, be not deaf to me" (v. 1).
2. "Hear the voice of my pleas for mercy, as I cry to you for help" (v. 2).
3. "Do not drag me off with the wicked" (v. 3).
4. "Because they do not regard the works of the LORD, or the work of his hands, he will tear them down and build them up no more" (v. 5).
5. "Blessed be the LORD! For he has heard the voice of my pleas for mercy" (v. 6).
6. "The LORD is my strength and my shield; in him my heart trusts, and I am helped" (v. 7).
7. "The LORD is the strength of his people; he is the saving refuge of his anointed" (v. 8).
8. "Oh, save your people and bless your heritage! Be their shepherd and carry them forever" (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David's fear is silence. "If you are deaf to me, I become like those who go down to the pit." He cannot bear the thought that God might not answer. He lifts his hands toward the holy sanctuary, and asks God not to treat him as he treats the wicked, whose speech is smooth but whose hearts are full of evil.

He prays for justice in verse 4, asking that they receive what their deeds deserve. This is not personal revenge. It is the cry for a righteous God to act against evil. The reason is verse 5: they do not regard the works of the LORD. They ignore him and act as though no one will answer.

Then, without a transition, the mood changes. "Blessed be the LORD! For he has heard the voice of my pleas for mercy." Between verses 5 and 6, something has happened. Perhaps a priest spoke a word of assurance, or perhaps David simply felt the burden lift. Whatever it was, he now says, "The LORD is my strength and my shield; in him my heart trusts, and I am helped; my heart exults, and with my song I give thanks to him."

The final verses widen the circle. The LORD is not just his strength but "the strength of his people." He is the saving refuge of his anointed. And David asks for the whole flock: "Save your people and bless your heritage. Be their shepherd and carry them forever." The same shepherd who walked with David is asked to carry all his people.

Jesus is the final Shepherd and the final Anointed. He cried out to his Father in distress and was heard. And now he carries his flock.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 23 and Ezekiel 34 describe the LORD as shepherd. Psalm 18:2 uses the same strength and shield language. Psalm 22:24 says he has not hidden his face but has heard when he cried to him. John 10:11-16 shows Jesus as the Good Shepherd. Hebrews 5:7 says Jesus offered up prayers with loud cries and tears, and was heard. 1 Peter 5:4 speaks of the Chief Shepherd.

STEP 6

Application

Take a burden to the LORD today, and keep praying until you can, like David, bless him.

Pray verse 9 for your church: save your people, bless them, shepherd them, and carry them.

Thank God for a time he heard you when you felt unheard.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to hear your pleas for mercy.
- Thank him that he is your strength and shield.
- Bless him for hearing you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 89

"Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance."

LUKE 15:7

DAY 619 · WEEK 89

Psalm 31:1-18

Into your hands I commit my spirit

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 31:1-18. This is a psalm of trust in deep distress. Verse 5 is the one Jesus prayed on the cross, and you will meet it again in Luke 23.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 31 is a psalm of David written when he was in danger, grieving, and slandered. It moves back and forth between trust and complaint, a mark of honest prayer. The first eighteen verses cover the prayer for refuge, the description of suffering, and the declaration, "My times are in your hand." The rest of the psalm (vv. 19 to 24) comes in a few days.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In you, O LORD, do I take refuge; let me never be put to shame; in your righteousness deliver me!" (v. 1).
2. "Be to me a rock of refuge, a strong fortress to save me!" (v. 2).
3. "For you are my rock and my fortress" (v. 3).
4. "Into your hand I commit my spirit; you have redeemed me, O LORD, faithful God" (v. 5).
5. "Be gracious to me, O LORD, for I am in distress" (v. 9).
6. "For my life is spent with sorrow, and my years with sighing" (v. 10).
7. "But I trust in you, O LORD; I say, You are my God" (v. 14).
8. "My times are in your hand" (v. 15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts with a refuge. David has run to the LORD, and he asks to be delivered. He uses the image of a rock and a fortress, and asks the LORD to lead and guide him "for your name's sake." Whatever happens, God's own honor is tied to his people.

Verse 5 is the center: "Into your hand I commit my spirit; you have redeemed me, O LORD, faithful God." This was a prayer a pious Jew might say at bedtime. It means, "I place my life in your keeping." Jesus will pray it on the cross, with one change: he begins with "Father." The prayer David prayed in danger is the prayer Jesus prayed in death, and it has been the prayer of many Christians in their last moments.

Then David describes his suffering. He is in distress. His eye, soul, and body waste away with grief. His strength fails because of his iniquity, and his bones waste away. He has become a reproach to his adversaries and an object of dread to his neighbors. People who see him flee from him. He is forgotten like one who is dead, a broken vessel. He hears the whispering of many, terror on every side, as they scheme to take his life.

And yet: "But I trust in you, O LORD; I say, You are my God." The word "but" turns the psalm. In the middle of terror he declares, "My times are in your hand." All of life's seasons, the good and the bad, are in God's hand. No enemy can reach beyond it. So he asks God to make his face shine on him and to save him in his steadfast love.

This is the heart of faith. It does not deny the pain, and it does not say the pain is small. It says that the pain is held by a hand that is good.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 23:46 has Jesus praying verse 5 on the cross. Acts 7:59 has Stephen praying a similar prayer at his death. Jonah 2:8 and Psalm 71:1-3 parallel the refuge language. Psalm 22 is also a psalm of suffering and trust. Romans 8:28 says God works all things together for good. 1 Peter 4:19 says to entrust your souls to a faithful Creator. 1 Peter 5:7 says to cast all your anxieties on him.

STEP 6

Application

Pray verse 5 tonight before you sleep, and let it become a habit.

Write "My times are in your hand" on a card and place it where you will see it.

Name a season of your life that feels out of control and entrust it to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Commit your spirit into God's hand, as Jesus did.

Tell him what you need as your refuge.

Thank him for redeeming you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 89

"Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance."

LUKE 15:7

DAY 620 · WEEK 89

Luke 13:22-15:32

The narrow door; the great banquet; the lost sheep, coin, son

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 13:22-15:32. The narrow door, a banquet where the guests make excuses, the cost of discipleship, and three parables about the lost: a sheep, a coin, and a son. Chapter 15 is among the most loved in the Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is still on the way to Jerusalem. Someone asks whether only a few will be saved, and Jesus replies with a warning. Then he dines with a Pharisee on the Sabbath and tells about banquets. Tax collectors and sinners draw near to hear him, and the Pharisees grumble. In response, Jesus tells three parables of lost things, and the third becomes the best known of all his stories.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Strive to enter through the narrow door” (13:24).
2. “O Jerusalem, Jerusalem, the city that kills the prophets… How often would I have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you were not willing!” (13:34).
3. “For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, and he who humbles himself will be exalted” (14:11).
4. “Go out to the highways and hedges and compel people to come in, that my house may be filled” (14:23).
5. “Whoever does not bear his own cross and come after me cannot be my disciple” (14:27).

6. “There will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance” (15:7).

7. “But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and felt compassion, and ran and embraced him and kissed him” (15:20).

8. “For this your brother was dead, and is alive; he was lost, and is found” (15:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Someone asks if only a few will be saved. Jesus does not answer with a number but with a command: strive to enter the narrow door. Many will seek to enter and not be able. The door will be shut, and those outside will say, “We ate and drank in your presence.” Being near Jesus is not the same as knowing him. Yet people will come from east, west, north, and south to sit at table in the kingdom, and “some who are last will be first.” Jesus mourns over Jerusalem like a mother hen. “You were not willing.”

At a Pharisee’s table, Jesus heals a man with dropsy, and teaches that the humble will be exalted. He tells the host to invite the poor, the crippled, the lame, and the blind, who cannot repay. Then he tells of a great banquet where invited guests make excuses. The master sends his servants to the poor, then to the highways and hedges. “That my house may be filled.” The kingdom is a feast, and the grace of the host reaches the outcast. Jesus then warns the crowds about the cost of following him. One must count the cost, like a builder or a king. No one can be his disciple without giving up everything.

The three parables of chapter 15 answer the grumbling Pharisees. A shepherd leaves ninety-nine to find one lost sheep, carries it home on his shoulders, and calls friends to rejoice. A woman sweeps the house for one lost coin, and rejoices when it is found. In each, the lost is sought and found, and heaven rejoices.

The third story is of a father and two sons. The younger son demands his inheritance, wastes it, and ends up feeding pigs. “He came to himself.” He plans a speech and heads home. “While he was still a long way off, his father saw him,” ran, embraced him, and kissed him. He interrupts the speech, calls for the best robe, a ring, sandals, and a feast. This is how God receives a returning sinner.

But there is an older brother, who stays outside, angry. He has been dutiful, yet he does not share his father’s joy. The father goes out to him, too: “All that is mine is yours. It was fitting to celebrate.” The story ends without telling us whether he goes in. Jesus leaves the Pharisees with the question. Will they join the feast, or stay outside?

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 55:6-7 invites the wicked to return to the LORD, who will abundantly pardon. Ezekiel 34:11-16 has God as the seeking shepherd. Psalm 103:8-13 says the LORD has compassion as a father has compassion on his children. Hosea 11 shows God's tender love for a wandering son. Matthew 7:13-14 parallels the narrow gate. Romans 5:8 says God shows his love in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us. Ephesians 2:13 says we who were far off have been brought near.

STEP 6

Application

Imagine yourself in the story as the younger son, then as the older. Which is harder to see in yourself?

Is there someone you have written off as lost? Pray for them by name.

Celebrate when someone repents or comes to faith. Heaven does.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for running to meet you while you were far off.
- Tell him where you have been the older brother.
- Rejoice with him over those who come home.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 89

"Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance."

LUKE 15:7

DAY 621 · WEEK 89

Luke 16:1-17:37

The rich man and Lazarus; faith; the coming kingdom

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 68 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 16:1-17:37. A shrewd manager, the rich man and Lazarus, warnings about stumbling, forgiveness, faith, ten lepers, and the coming of the kingdom. These are hard sayings. Read slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

On the road to Jerusalem, Jesus continues to teach the disciples while the Pharisees, who love money, listen and scoff. His teaching in these chapters keeps coming back to money, faithfulness, and readiness for the kingdom. Luke 16 is the most pointed teaching on wealth in the Gospels.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “One who is faithful in a very little is also faithful in much” (16:10).
2. “You cannot serve God and money” (16:13).
3. “Son, remember that you in your lifetime received your good things, and Lazarus in like manner bad things” (16:25).
4. “If they do not hear Moses and the Prophets, neither will they be convinced if someone should rise from the dead” (16:31).
5. “Increase our faith!” (17:5).
6. “If you had faith like a grain of mustard seed” (17:6).
7. “Were not ten cleansed? Where are the nine?” (17:17).
8. “For behold, the kingdom of God is in the midst of you” (17:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The parable of the shrewd manager is puzzling. A manager, about to be fired, reduces the debts of his master's debtors to make friends. The master commends his shrewdness. Jesus does not praise dishonesty. The point is that the people of this age plan ahead for their future, so the children of light should use worldly wealth with an eye to eternity. "Make friends for yourselves by means of unrighteous wealth." Money is a tool, not a master: "You cannot serve God and money." The Pharisees sneer, and Jesus tells them that what is exalted among men is an abomination in the sight of God.

Then comes the rich man and Lazarus. A rich man dresses in purple and feasts daily, while a beggar named Lazarus lies at his gate covered with sores. Both die. Lazarus is carried by angels to Abraham's side, and the rich man is in torment. This is the only parable in which a character has a name, and he is the poor one. The rich man asks Abraham to send Lazarus to warn his brothers. Abraham answers, "They have Moses and the Prophets." If they do not listen to Scripture, they will not be convinced even by one who rises from the dead. The story is a warning about hardened hearts, and an irony: someone did rise from the dead, and many did not believe.

Chapter 17 begins with a warning about causing little ones to stumble, and a call to forgive repeatedly. The apostles say, "Increase our faith!" Jesus replies that faith the size of a mustard seed can do surprising things. It is not the quantity but the object that matters. Then he tells them that servants who have done all that was commanded say, "We are unworthy servants."

Ten lepers are healed, and only one returns to give thanks, a Samaritan. Jesus says, "Your faith has made you well." Then the Pharisees ask when the kingdom will come, and Jesus replies, "The kingdom of God is in the midst of you." The King is standing among them. He then speaks of the days of the Son of Man, which will come suddenly like lightning, and warns, "Remember Lot's wife."

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 15:7-11 commands generosity toward the poor. Proverbs 14:31 says whoever oppresses the poor shows contempt for his Maker. Isaiah 8:19-20 sends people to the law and the testimony. Matthew 6:24 has the same saying about two masters. Luke 24:25-27 returns to the importance of Moses and the Prophets. 1 Timothy 6:17-19 gives instructions to the rich. 2 Kings 5 recounts the healing of Naaman, the leper who was a foreigner. 1 Thessalonians 5:18 says to give thanks in all circumstances.

STEP 6

Application

Look at your own giving and spending. Are you using money as a tool for eternity?

Be the one leper who returns. Write a thank you note to God or to someone who has helped you.

Read your Bible faithfully. Moses and the Prophets still speak.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you are tempted to serve besides him, such as money.
- Ask him to open your eyes to the “Lazarus” at your gate.
- Ask him to teach you to be faithful in little.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 89

“Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance.”

LUKE 15:7

DAY 622 · WEEK 89

Luke 18:1-19:27

The widow and judge; the Pharisee and the tax collector; Zacchaeus

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 70 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 18:1-19:27. Two parables about prayer, children brought to Jesus, a rich ruler, a blind man healed, and Zacchaeus. Chapter 19:10 is the key verse of the whole Gospel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is near the end of his journey. He is about to enter Jericho and then go up to Jerusalem. These chapters hold several of Luke's best known scenes: the Pharisee and the tax collector, Zacchaeus, and the parable of the minas. They show who receives the kingdom: the humble, the childlike, the despised, and the seeking.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He told them a parable to the effect that they ought always to pray and not lose heart" (18:1).
2. "And will not God give justice to his elect, who cry to him day and night?" (18:7).
3. "God, be merciful to me, a sinner!" (18:13).
4. "For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, but the one who humbles himself will be exalted" (18:14).
5. "Let the children come to me, and do not hinder them, for to such belongs the kingdom of God" (18:16).
6. "What is impossible with men is possible with God" (18:27).
7. "Zacchaeus, hurry and come down, for I must stay at your house today" (19:5).
8. "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost" (19:10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The widow and the unjust judge teach persistence. A widow keeps coming to a judge who neither fears God nor respects people, and finally he gives her justice because she wears him out. If even an unjust judge responds, how much more will God, who is just and loving, answer his chosen ones? The lesson is to pray always and not lose heart.

The Pharisee and the tax collector teach humility. The Pharisee stands and thanks God that he is not like other men. The tax collector stands far off, beats his chest, and says, "God, be merciful to me, a sinner!" Jesus says this man went down to his house justified. Justification comes through humble faith in God's mercy, not through the record of our good deeds.

Parents bring infants to Jesus, and the disciples try to stop them. Jesus welcomes them and says the kingdom belongs to such as these, and that whoever does not receive it like a child will not enter it. Then a rich ruler asks what he must do to inherit eternal life. Jesus points him to the commandments, and then says to sell everything and follow him. The man goes away sad, for he is very rich. Jesus says it is hard for the rich to enter the kingdom. The bystanders ask, "Who then can be saved?" and Jesus answers, "What is impossible with men is possible with God." Salvation is a miracle.

For the third time, Jesus speaks of his death in Jerusalem. The disciples do not understand. Outside Jericho, a blind beggar cries, "Jesus, Son of David, have mercy on me!" The crowd tells him to be quiet, but he cries out louder. Jesus heals him, and he follows, glorifying God.

In Jericho, Zacchaeus, a chief tax collector and wealthy, climbs a sycamore tree to see Jesus. Jesus calls him by name and invites himself to his house. The crowd grumbles. Zacchaeus repents, gives half his goods to the poor, and repays fourfold anyone he cheated. Jesus says, "Today salvation has come to this house." Then verse 10 summarizes his whole mission: "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost." The parable of the minas follows, to correct the idea that the kingdom will appear at once. The King is going away, and his servants are to be faithful until he returns.

STEP 5

Connection

Habakkuk 2:4 says the righteous shall live by his faith. Psalm 51:1-4 is the prayer of a broken sinner. Psalm 34:18 says the LORD is near to the brokenhearted. Isaiah 66:2 says God looks to the humble and contrite. Ezekiel 34:16 promises that God will seek the lost. Romans 3:21-26 explains justification by faith. Luke 15 gave three parables of the lost. 1 Timothy 1:15 says Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners.

STEP 6

Application

Pray the tax collector's prayer slowly, ten times: "God, be merciful to me, a sinner."

Keep praying for the thing you have prayed about for the longest time. Do not lose heart.

Ask who the Zacchaeus is in your life, someone others have written off. Reach out to them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to teach you to pray always and not lose heart.
- Pray, "God, be merciful to me, a sinner," and mean it.
- Thank Jesus for receiving sinners like Zacchaeus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 89

"Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance."

LUKE 15:7

DAY 623 · WEEK 89

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Luke 15:7 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance."

LUKE 15:7

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this at the end of the parable of the lost sheep, to Pharisees who complained that he welcomed sinners and ate with them. It is his answer to their grumbling and a window into the heart of heaven.

"Just so." The shepherd's joy over the found sheep is a picture of heaven's joy. Jesus is not describing an anxious God who tolerates repentant sinners. He is describing a God who celebrates.

"More joy in heaven." Heaven is not a quiet place. It rejoices. When a single person turns from sin and trusts in God, the angels rejoice and the Father himself is glad. Your repentance was a reason for celebration in heaven.

“One sinner who repents.” One, not a crowd. Each person matters to God. The shepherd left ninety-nine to seek one. Repentance here means a change of mind and direction, turning from self and sin to God.

“Ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance.” Jesus says this with irony, for the Pharisees thought they were righteous. In truth, everyone needs to repent. The only people who miss the party are those who think they do not need it.

If you have ever felt that God is disappointed in you, say this verse. When you come home, he runs to meet you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you prayed Psalm 27 and its bold trust, “Whom shall I fear?”, and Psalm 28, which moves from a cry to praise. Psalm 31:1-18 gave you the prayer “Into your hand I commit my spirit,” and “My times are in your hand.” In Luke 13 to 19 you heard Jesus warn about the narrow door and tell the stories of the lost sheep, the lost coin, and the lost son, in which a father runs to meet a returning child. You listened to his hard words about money, the rich man and Lazarus, the ten lepers, and the coming of the kingdom. You saw a widow persist in prayer, a tax collector go home justified, a blind man receive his sight, and Zacchaeus climb down from a tree. You read the verse that sums up the Gospel: “The Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost.”

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

In the parable of the lost son, the father runs to meet the returning child. What does this tell you about how God receives you when you come back to him?

Jesus said he came to seek and to save the lost (19:10). How does his seeking of Zacchaeus, and of you, show who Jesus is?

The tax collector prayed, “God, be merciful to me, a sinner.” Where do you need to stop justifying yourself and simply ask for mercy?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that heaven rejoices over one sinner who repents.

Thank him for seeking you and bringing you home.

Ask him to keep you from the elder brother’s spirit.

DAY 624 · WEEK 90

Luke 19:28-21:38

The Entry; controversies; the widow's offering; signs of the end

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 116 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 19:28-21:38. The King rides into Jerusalem, weeps over the city, cleanses the temple, and teaches there while the leaders try to trap him. It ends with his words about the end of the age. Read it as the week before the cross.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The long journey is over. Jesus comes to Jerusalem at the time of Passover. For the next few days he teaches in the temple, answering questions from priests, scribes, Pharisees, Sadducees, and the Herodians. Each group tries to catch him in his words, and each is silenced. Luke records the events in an orderly way, and the shadow of the cross lies over every scene.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed is the King who comes in the name of the Lord! Peace in heaven and glory in the highest!" (19:38).
2. "Would that you, even you, had known on this day the things that make for peace!" (19:42).
3. "It is written, And my house shall be a house of prayer, but you have made it a den of robbers" (19:46).
4. "The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone" (20:17).
5. "Then render to Caesar the things that are Caesar's, and to God the things that are God's" (20:25).
6. "Now he is not God of the dead but of the living, for all live to him" (20:38).

7. “Truly, I tell you, this poor widow has put in more than all of them” (21:3).

8. “Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away” (21:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus sends two disciples for a colt that no one has ever ridden. As he rides toward the city, the crowd of disciples spreads cloaks on the road and cries out, “Blessed is the King who comes in the name of the Lord!” Zechariah 9:9 is being fulfilled. When the Pharisees ask him to rebuke them, he says that if they were silent, the very stones would cry out.

But as he draws near and sees the city, he weeps. He knows that Jerusalem does not recognize the time of her visitation, and he foretells its destruction, which came in AD 70. The King who enters in triumph weeps for those who reject him.

In the temple he drives out those who sell, saying the house is meant to be a house of prayer. Then he teaches daily, and the chief priests and scribes seek to destroy him but cannot find a way, because all the people hang on his words.

They challenge his authority, and he answers with a question about John’s baptism. They will not answer, so neither will he. Then he tells the parable of the wicked tenants. A man plants a vineyard and sends servants, who are beaten, and finally his beloved son, whom they kill. This is the story of Israel’s leaders and of Jesus himself. He quotes Psalm 118: the rejected stone becomes the cornerstone.

Then come the traps. Is it lawful to pay taxes to Caesar? “Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar’s, and to God the things that are God’s.” The Sadducees, who deny the resurrection, ask about the woman married to seven brothers. Jesus answers that those who rise are like angels and that God is the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, “not God of the dead but of the living.” Then Jesus asks his own question: how can the Christ be David’s son, when David calls him Lord (Psalm 110)? Because he is both. Jesus warns against the scribes who devour widows’ houses, and then points out a poor widow who put in two small coins. She gave all she had.

The last chapter is the Olivet discourse, speaking of the destruction of the temple, persecution, signs in the sun, moon, and stars, and the coming of the Son of Man with power and great glory. Jesus’ call is: “Straighten up and raise your heads, because your redemption is drawing near.” Stay awake, and pray that you may have strength to stand before the Son of Man. Interpreters differ on how to divide what refers to AD 70 and what refers to the end of the age, but the pastoral aim is clear: be watchful, and do not be afraid.

STEP 5

Connection

Zechariah 9:9 is the prophecy of the humble king on a donkey. Psalm 118:22-26 is the background to the crowd's shout and the cornerstone. Isaiah 5:1-7 is the vineyard song behind the tenants. Psalm 110:1 is the verse Jesus asks about. Jeremiah 7:11 is the "den of robbers." Daniel 7:13-14 describes the Son of Man coming with the clouds. Exodus 3:6 is the verse Jesus cites for the resurrection. Romans 13:1-7 teaches about the state.

STEP 6

Application

Welcome Jesus as King today. Is there an area of your life where you would rather he not enter?

Give something to God out of what you need, not just out of your surplus, like the widow.

Practice watchfulness. Pray for strength for whatever is ahead.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Welcome Jesus as King, and tell him what you want to lay at his feet.
- Ask him to give you tears for what he weeps over.
- Ask him to teach you to give, like the widow, all you have.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 90

"This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me."

LUKE 22:19

DAY 625 · WEEK 90

Psalm 31:19-24

Oh, how abundant is your goodness

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 31:19-24. This is the second half of the psalm you read on Day 619. After the trouble, the singer turns to thanks. Read it with the verses 1 to 18 fresh in your mind.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first half of Psalm 31 was a prayer in the middle of distress. These closing verses look back from the other side. David has been heard, and he reflects on the goodness of God that is stored up for those who trust him. He ends by calling all God's people to love him and take courage.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh, how abundant is your goodness" (v. 19).
2. "stored up for those who fear you" (v. 19).
3. "In the cover of your presence you hide them from the plots of men" (v. 20).
4. "he has wondrously shown his steadfast love to me when I was in a besieged city" (v. 21).
5. "I had said in my alarm, I am cut off from your sight" (v. 22).
6. "you heard the voice of my pleas for mercy" (v. 22).
7. "Love the LORD, all you his saints!" (v. 23).
8. "Be strong, and let your heart take courage, all who wait for the LORD!" (v. 24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Verse 19 is an exclamation: “Oh, how abundant is your goodness!” David is overwhelmed. The goodness of God is not scarce, and it is stored up, like treasure in a storehouse, for those who fear him and take refuge in him. It is given “in the sight of the children of mankind,” so that others can see.

Verse 20 describes how it is delivered. God hides his people “in the cover of your presence” from the plots of men and “in your shelter from the strife of tongues.” David had been slandered (see verse 13), and he knows that God’s nearness is the safest place.

In verse 21, he blesses the LORD for showing steadfast love in a “besieged city.” He had felt trapped, surrounded, and helpless. Then he admits, “I had said in my alarm, I am cut off from your sight.” This is the honest confession of a believer who felt abandoned. But he was not. “You heard the voice of my pleas for mercy when I cried to you for help.” What he felt in alarm was not the truth. God had been listening all along.

Then David turns outward. “Love the LORD, all you his saints!” He has learned something he wants others to know. The LORD preserves the faithful, and abundantly repays the proud. And the last words are an encouragement: “Be strong, and let your heart take courage, all who wait for the LORD.”

Read this beside Luke 19 to 21. Jesus entered a besieged city in the week of his death. He felt the plots of men. Yet he was not cut off, and the Father vindicated him. And because of the cross, the goodness stored up for those who take refuge in God is ours.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 27:13-14 ends with almost the same call to wait and take courage. Psalm 34:8-10 says to taste and see that the LORD is good. Isaiah 64:4 and 1 Corinthians 2:9 speak of what God has prepared for those who wait for him. Romans 8:35-39 says nothing can separate us from the love of God. Ephesians 1:3 says he has blessed us with every spiritual blessing. Jonah 2:4 echoes the feeling of being cast out from his sight.

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of the goodness God has stored up and given you. Thank him for each one.

Remember a time you felt cut off from God and he was close. Write it down.

Tell a friend, as David does: love the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for goodness he has stored up for those who fear him.

Thank him for hiding you in the cover of his presence.

Ask him to make you strong and take heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 90

"This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me."

LUKE 22:19

DAY 626 · WEEK 90

Psalm 41

Blessed is the one who considers the poor

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 41. It closes the first book of the Psalter. Notice verse 9, which Jesus applies to Judas in John 13, and the blessing for those who care for the poor at the beginning.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 41 is a psalm of David written in illness, when enemies gloated and a close friend turned against him. It begins with a beatitude for the one who considers the poor, and it ends with a doxology that closes the first of the five books of the Psalms. It comes in the plan at the point in Luke where the shadow of betrayal falls.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Blessed is the one who considers the poor! In the day of trouble the LORD delivers him” (v. 1).
2. “The LORD sustains him on his sickbed; in his illness you restore him to full health” (v. 3).
3. “As for me, I said, O LORD, be gracious to me; heal me, for I have sinned against you!” (v. 4).
4. “My enemies say of me in malice: When will he die, and his name perish?” (v. 5).
5. “Even my close friend in whom I trusted, who ate my bread, has lifted his heel against me” (v. 9).
6. “By this I know that you delight in me: my enemy will not shout in triumph over me” (v. 11).

7. “But you have upheld me because of my integrity, and set me in your presence forever” (v. 12).

8. “Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, from everlasting to everlasting! Amen and Amen” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a blessing on those who consider the poor. This means paying attention, thinking about, and caring for the weak. The reward is that the LORD delivers them in the day of trouble, protects them, keeps them alive, and sustains them on a sickbed.

Then David turns to his own distress. He is sick, and he prays, “O LORD, be gracious to me; heal me, for I have sinned against you!” He does not claim innocence. He asks for mercy, trusting that God’s grace is greater than his guilt.

His enemies wait for him to die. Visitors come with empty words, and then go out to spread slander. “They imagine the worst for me.” Then comes the sharpest pain: “Even my close friend in whom I trusted, who ate my bread, has lifted his heel against me.” Betrayal by someone who shared your table is a particular kind of grief.

Jesus quotes this verse at the Last Supper (John 13:18) about Judas. David’s betrayal by his friend, probably Ahithophel, is a pattern of the greater betrayal of the Son of David. In Luke 22, Jesus eats the Passover with his betrayer at the table.

David asks to be raised up, so that he may repay them. But he trusts that God delights in him because the enemy has not triumphed. “You have upheld me because of my integrity, and set me in your presence forever.” David’s integrity is not sinlessness but the sincerity of one who has confessed and been forgiven. The end of the psalm is the doxology that closes Book I: “Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, from everlasting to everlasting! Amen and Amen.”

For Christians, the one who truly considered the poor, who bore betrayal, and who was upheld and raised up forever, is Jesus.

STEP 5

Connection

John 13:18 quotes verse 9. 2 Samuel 15 to 17 tells of Ahithophel’s betrayal of David. Matthew 26:14-16 and Luke 22:3-6 describe Judas’s betrayal. Proverbs 14:21 and 19:17 speak of kindness to the poor. Psalm 72:12-14 says the king delivers the needy. 2 Corinthians 8:9 says Christ became poor for our sake. Matthew 25:31-46 describes the judgment in terms of care for the least.

STEP 6

Application

Consider the poor this week: give, visit, or serve someone in need.

If you have been betrayed, bring it to the LORD in prayer. Forgive as he leads you.

Pray David's prayer in verse 4 honestly, naming your sins and asking for grace.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to be gracious and heal you, and tell him your sin.
- Ask him to teach you to consider the poor.
- Thank Jesus, who knows the pain of betrayal.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 90

"This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me."

LUKE 22:19

DAY 627 · WEEK 90

Psalm 55:1-23

My companion stretched out his hand against me

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 55:1-23. David's closest friend betrays him, and he longs to fly away. Notice the turn in verse 22, and read it against the betrayal in Luke 22.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 55 is a psalm of David, probably from the time of Absalom's rebellion, when his trusted advisor Ahithophel joined the conspiracy. David is in anguish. The city is full of violence, and the one who hurt him the most was a friend. It is one of the most honest psalms about betrayal, and it ends with one of the most quoted verses in the Psalter.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give ear to my prayer, O God, and hide not yourself from my plea for mercy!" (v. 1).
2. "My heart is in anguish within me; the terrors of death have fallen upon me" (v. 4).
3. "Oh, that I had wings like a dove! I would fly away and be at rest" (v. 6).
4. "But it is you, a man, my equal, my companion, my familiar friend" (v. 13).
5. "We used to take sweet counsel together; within God's house we walked in the throng" (v. 14).
6. "His speech was smooth as butter, yet war was in his heart" (v. 21).
7. "Cast your burden on the LORD, and he will sustain you; he will never permit the righteous to be moved" (v. 22).
8. "But I will trust in you" (v. 23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David begins with a plea: “Give ear to my prayer.” He is restless, he moans, his heart is in anguish. Fear and trembling overwhelm him, and horror covers him. In the middle of that, he wishes he could escape: “Oh, that I had wings like a dove! I would fly away and be at rest.” Everyone has felt this. We want to flee the pain, find a quiet place, and wait out the storm.

The city is full of violence and strife, and iniquity and trouble are within it. But what hurts most is not the enemy outside. “It is not an enemy who taunts me; then I could bear it… But it is you, a man, my equal, my companion, my familiar friend.” They had walked together to the house of God. The betrayer had broken covenant. His speech was smooth as butter, “yet war was in his heart.”

Notice what David does. He does not hide his rage. He asks God to confuse the tongues of the wicked and to bring them down. But he also does something more: he calls on God, evening, morning, and noon, and God hears.

And then, the center of the psalm: “Cast your burden on the LORD, and he will sustain you; he will never permit the righteous to be moved.” David speaks to himself and to us. A burden you cannot carry can be put on someone who can. The word here is gift or lot, whatever has been given to you. Give it to the LORD, and he will hold you up. The final line is a short declaration: “But I will trust in you.”

Peter later quotes this verse: “Casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you.” And Jesus, betrayed in a garden by a friend with a kiss, lived this psalm. He cast his burden on the Father. In Gethsemane he prayed, “Not my will, but yours,” and he was sustained. His betrayal means that when we are betrayed, we have a High Priest who understands.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Samuel 15:12 and 17:23 tell of Ahithophel’s betrayal and death. Psalm 41:9 uses the same betrayal imagery. Matthew 26:47-50 shows Judas’s kiss. Luke 22:48 is Jesus’ word to Judas. 1 Peter 5:7 quotes verse 22. Philippians 4:6-7 invites us to bring everything to God in prayer. Hebrews 4:15 says Jesus can sympathize with our weaknesses. Matthew 11:28 invites the weary to come to him.

STEP 6

Application

Name your burden aloud and give it to the LORD. Do it again when it returns.

If you are tempted to run, ask where you can find rest, then go to him in prayer.

Pray for the one who hurt you. Entrust the justice to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God the anguish of your heart.
- Cast your burden on him and tell him what it is.
- Thank him that he sustains you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 90

"This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me."

LUKE 22:19

DAY 628 · WEEK 90

Luke 22:1-46

The Last Supper; teaching on greatness; Gethsemane

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 46 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 22:1-46. The plot, the betrayal bargain, the Last Supper, the argument about greatness, Peter's warning, and Gethsemane. Read slowly, and let the Supper words settle.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is the week of Passover. The religious leaders are looking for a way to put Jesus to death without upsetting the people. Satan enters Judas. In an upper room, Jesus eats the Passover with his disciples and gives the meal a new meaning. Then he leads them to the Mount of Olives to pray, as was his custom. Luke's account is among the most intimate in the Gospels.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Then Satan entered into Judas called Iscariot, who was of the number of the twelve" (22:3).
2. "I have earnestly desired to eat this Passover with you before I suffer" (22:15).
3. "This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me" (22:19).
4. "This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood" (22:20).
5. "But not so with you. Rather, let the greatest among you become as the youngest, and the leader as one who serves" (22:26).
6. "But I have prayed for you that your faith may not fail. And when you have turned again, strengthen your brothers" (22:32).
7. "Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me. Nevertheless, not my will, but yours, be done" (22:42).

8 “Why are you sleeping? Rise and pray that you may not enter into temptation” (22:46).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Luke moves quickly. The leaders are afraid of the people, and Satan enters Judas, who agrees to betray Jesus for money. Meanwhile Jesus sends Peter and John to prepare the Passover meal.

At the table, Jesus says, “I have earnestly desired to eat this Passover with you before I suffer.” He takes bread and says, “This is my body, given for you,” and after supper takes the cup and says, “This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood.” This is the heart of the chapter. The Passover remembered the lamb whose blood spared Israel in Egypt. Now Jesus says that his body and blood will be given for his people. He is the Lamb, and the new covenant promised in Jeremiah 31 is being inaugurated by his death. Christians have disagreed about exactly how Christ is present in the Supper, but all agree that he commanded the church to keep it, and that it proclaims his death until he comes.

At the table, Jesus names his betrayer, and the disciples argue about which of them is the greatest. It is one of the saddest scenes in the Gospels. Jesus answers with a reversal: the kings of the Gentiles lord it over them, but “not so with you.” The greatest must be as the youngest, and the leader as one who serves. “I am among you as the one who serves.” Then he promises that they will sit on thrones, a covenant of kingdom from his Father.

He turns to Peter: “Satan demanded to have you, that he might sift you like wheat, but I have prayed for you that your faith may not fail.” Notice that Jesus does not say he will keep Peter from falling. He says he has prayed that his faith will not fail, and that Peter will turn again and strengthen his brothers. Jesus foretells Peter’s denial, and Peter swears he will never deny him.

On the Mount of Olives, Jesus withdraws a stone’s throw and prays: “Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me. Nevertheless, not my will, but yours, be done.” An angel strengthens him. Then in agony he prays more earnestly. (Some early manuscripts omit verses 43 and 44, but the scene they describe fits the whole.) He finds the disciples sleeping from sorrow. “Rise and pray that you may not enter into temptation.” The Son does what Adam did not: he submits to the will of the Father.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 12 is the Passover. Jeremiah 31:31-34 promises the new covenant. Isaiah 53:12 says he poured out his soul to death. 1 Corinthians 11:23-26 is Paul’s account of the Supper. Hebrews 5:7-8 describes the prayers and cries of Jesus. Mark 10:42-45 is the parallel on servant

leadership. John 13:1-17 shows Jesus washing the disciples' feet. 1 Peter 5:8 warns that the devil prowls like a roaring lion.

STEP 6

Application

When you receive the Lord's Supper, think about each word: broken for you, poured out for you.

Practice the service of the one who serves. Do something humble for someone today, unseen if possible.

Pray Jesus' prayer in your hardest decision: "Not my will, but yours."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for the Passover he earnestly desired to eat with his disciples.
- Tell him about the cup you are afraid to drink, and pray, "Not my will but yours."
- Ask him to help you stay awake and pray.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 90

"This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me."

LUKE 22:19

DAY 629 · WEEK 90

Luke 22:47-23:25

Arrest; trials; Peter's denial; before Pilate and Herod

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 22:47-23:25. The arrest, Peter's denial, the mockery, and the trials before the council, Pilate, and Herod. Notice how many times Jesus is declared innocent.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Judas arrives with a crowd, and Jesus is arrested at night. He is taken to the high priest's house while Peter follows at a distance. Before dawn he stands before the council, then before Pilate, the Roman governor, then Herod Antipas, and again Pilate. Luke stresses that Jesus is innocent. Pilate says so three times, and Herod finds nothing worthy of death.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Judas, would you betray the Son of Man with a kiss?" (22:48).
2. "But this is your hour, and the power of darkness" (22:53).
3. "And the Lord turned and looked at Peter. And Peter remembered the saying of the Lord" (22:61).
4. "And he went out and wept bitterly" (22:62).
5. "You say that I am" (22:70).
6. "I find no guilt in this man" (23:4).
7. "Why? What evil has he done? I have found in him no guilt deserving death" (23:22).
8. "But he delivered Jesus over to their will" (23:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus is arrested in the garden. A disciple cuts off the ear of the high priest's servant, and Jesus says, "No more of this!" and heals the ear. This is the last healing Luke records, and it is for one of those arresting him. Jesus tells the crowd, "This is your hour, and the power of darkness." Everything is happening by God's plan, yet the guilt is real.

Peter follows at a distance, and in the courtyard denies knowing Jesus three times. Then the rooster crows, and "the Lord turned and looked at Peter." Only Luke tells us this. In that look Peter remembered, "and he went out and wept bitterly." The look was not condemnation but love. Jesus had prayed for Peter, and the prayer was working.

Jesus is mocked and beaten. At dawn the council asks if he is the Christ, and he replies, "From now on the Son of Man shall be seated at the right hand of the power of God." They ask, "Are you the Son of God?" and he says, "You say that I am." They have what they want.

They take him to Pilate and accuse him of misleading the nation, forbidding tribute to Caesar, and claiming to be a king. Pilate asks if he is the King of the Jews and then declares, "I find no guilt in this man." When he learns Jesus is a Galilean, he sends him to Herod, who has wanted to see him for a long time and hopes for a sign. Jesus is silent. Herod and his soldiers mock him and send him back. "That same day Herod and Pilate became friends." The powers of the world unite against the Son of God.

Pilate tries three times to release him. "I have found in him no guilt deserving death." But the crowd shouts, "Crucify him!" and asks for Barabbas, a murderer. Pilate gives in. "He delivered Jesus over to their will." An innocent man took the place of a guilty one. Barabbas is a picture of every sinner: set free because Jesus stood in his place.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 53:7 says he opened not his mouth. Psalm 41:9 and 55:12-14 describe betrayal by a friend. Zechariah 13:7 foretold the striking of the shepherd. Isaiah 50:6 describes the servant who gave his back to those who strike. Psalm 2:1-2 describes the rulers gathering against the LORD and his anointed. Acts 4:25-28 applies that psalm to Herod and Pilate. 1 Peter 2:22-24 says he committed no sin and bore our sins in his body.

STEP 6

Application

Consider Peter. Have you denied Jesus in word or silence? Let his look of love meet you, and weep as Peter did.

Notice how the innocent one is silent. Where do you need to hold your tongue?

Thank Jesus for being your Barabbas substitute.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for being betrayed, denied, and mocked for you.

Confess where you have denied him.

Thank him that he looked at Peter, and ask him to look at you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 90

“This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me.”

LUKE 22:19

DAY 630 · WEEK 90

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Luke 22:19 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me."

LUKE 22:19

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this at the table on the night before his death. He takes the Passover bread, gives thanks, breaks it, and gives it to his disciples. In a few hours he will be arrested, and he knows it.

"This is my body." At the Passover, Israel ate bread and remembered the exodus. Jesus takes the bread of that meal and attaches it to himself. His body will be broken, and the true exodus from sin and death will come through him. Christians have understood the exact nature of the bread in different ways, but all hold that this meal is about Christ.

"Which is given for you." The word "for" is the heart of the gospel. He is not simply a martyr or an example. His body is given in your place, on your behalf. And it is personal: for you.

"Do this." Jesus gives a command. The Lord's Supper is not optional for the church. It is a gift and an instruction, and it has been kept for two thousand years.

“In remembrance of me.” To remember in the Bible is more than recalling a fact. It is to bring the past into the present, to be fed by it, and to proclaim it. When we take the bread and the cup, we look back to the cross, look up to the risen Christ, and look forward to the day he comes again.

When you doubt that you are loved, say this verse. His body was given for you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read Psalm 31:19-24, where the goodness of God is stored up for those who fear him, and Psalm 41 and Psalm 55, where David’s own friend lifted his heel against him, and where he learned to cast his burden on the LORD. In Luke 19 to 21 the King rode into Jerusalem, wept over it, cleansed the temple, and silenced every question. He praised a poor widow and spoke of his return. In Luke 22 and 23 you came to the upper room, where Jesus gave the bread and the cup of the new covenant, and to Gethsemane, where he prayed, “Not my will, but yours.” You watched him be betrayed with a kiss, denied by Peter, mocked, declared innocent three times, and handed over to the crowd in place of Barabbas.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said his body was given “for you” and his blood poured out for you. What does it mean to you personally that he did this?

In Gethsemane, Jesus prayed, “Not my will, but yours, be done.” How does his submission to the Father shape the way you pray when you face something hard?

Peter denied Jesus, and Jesus looked at him. Where do you need to receive that look of love, rather than of condemnation?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Remember Jesus with the bread and the cup, in your own words.

Thank him for his body given and his blood poured out.

Rest in what he did.

DAY 631 · WEEK 91

Luke 23:26-56

The crucifixion, "Father, forgive them"; the burial

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 23:26-56. The road to the cross, the crucifixion, two criminals, the death of Jesus, and his burial. This is the center of the Gospel. Read slowly and in silence if you can.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is led out of Jerusalem to a place called The Skull, carrying his cross, and a bystander, Simon of Cyrene, is forced to carry it for him. A great crowd follows, including women who mourn. Luke's account is marked by mercy. Even on the cross, Jesus forgives his killers and promises paradise to a dying criminal.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Daughters of Jerusalem, do not weep for me, but weep for yourselves and for your children" (23:28).
2. "Father, forgive them, for they know not what they do" (23:34).
3. "He saved others; let him save himself, if he is the Christ of God, his Chosen One!" (23:35).
4. "Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom" (23:42).
5. "Truly, I say to you, today you will be with me in paradise" (23:43).
6. "And the curtain of the temple was torn in two" (23:45).
7. "Father, into your hands I commit my spirit!" (23:46).
8. "Now there was a man named Joseph… a good and righteous man" (23:50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

On the way, Jesus turns to the weeping women and tells them to weep for themselves and for their children. He is thinking of Jerusalem's coming judgment. Even on his way to die, he cares for others.

At the cross, they crucify him between two criminals. His first words in Luke's account are a prayer: "Father, forgive them, for they know not what they do." This is the opposite of what any of us would pray. The soldiers divide his garments by lot, the rulers sneer, the soldiers mock him, and a sign over his head reads, "This is the King of the Jews." The mockers say, "Save yourself." They don't realize that he is saving others precisely by not saving himself.

One criminal joins the mockery. The other rebukes him: "Do you not fear God?" He acknowledges that they are justly condemned, but this man has done nothing wrong. Then he says, "Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom." This is faith in its barest form. He has no good works, no time to be baptized, and no way to make amends. He asks only to be remembered. And Jesus answers, "Today you will be with me in paradise." This is the gospel in a sentence: salvation by grace through faith, immediately, for a dying thief.

Darkness covers the land for three hours, and the curtain of the temple tears in two. The way into the presence of God is now open through the death of Jesus. Then he cries with a loud voice, "Father, into your hands I commit my spirit!" He quotes Psalm 31:5, which you prayed on Day 619, and breathes his last. He does not lose his life. He gives it. The centurion praises God and says, "Certainly this man was innocent!" The crowds go home beating their breasts.

Joseph of Arimathea, a member of the council who had not consented to the plan, asks for the body and lays it in a new tomb. The women from Galilee see where it is laid, prepare spices, and rest on the Sabbath according to the commandment. The body is in the tomb. Everything depends on what happens next.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 53:4-12 describes the servant who bore our griefs, was numbered with the transgressors, and made intercession. Psalm 22 begins with the cry of forsakenness and ends in praise. Psalm 31:5 is the prayer Jesus prays. Exodus 26:31-33 describes the curtain before the Holy of Holies. Hebrews 10:19-22 says we have confidence to enter the holy places by the blood of Jesus. Romans 5:8 shows his love for sinners. Acts 7:60 has Stephen echoing the prayer for forgiveness.

STEP 6

Application

Sit with the cross for ten minutes in silence. Do not rush to the resurrection.

Pray the thief's prayer: "Jesus, remember me." It is enough.

Forgive someone as Jesus forgave. If you can't yet, ask him for the willingness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for praying, "Father, forgive them," and ask him to forgive you.

Pray the thief's prayer: "Jesus, remember me."

Thank him for the promise of paradise.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 91

"And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth."

JOHN 1:14

DAY 632 · WEEK 91

Luke 24:1-53

The resurrection; Emmaus; the ascension

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Luke 24:1-53. The empty tomb, the road to Emmaus, the appearance to the disciples, and the ascension. This is the climax of the Gospel and the key to reading the whole Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

On the first day of the week, at early dawn, the women come to the tomb with spices. The disciples are scattered and afraid. Luke's last chapter takes place in a single day: the morning at the tomb, the afternoon on the road to Emmaus, and the evening in Jerusalem. It ends with the ascension, and leads straight into the book of Acts.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Why do you seek the living among the dead? He is not here, but has risen" (24:5-6).
2. "But we had hoped that he was the one to redeem Israel" (24:21).
3. "O foolish ones, and slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have spoken!" (24:25).
4. "And beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself" (24:27).
5. "Did not our hearts burn within us while he talked to us on the road, while he opened to us the Scriptures?" (24:32).
6. "See my hands and my feet, that it is I myself. Touch me, and see" (24:39).
7. "Thus it is written, that the Christ should suffer and on the third day rise from the dead, and that repentance for the forgiveness of sins should be proclaimed in his name to all nations" (24:46-47).

8 “And they worshiped him and returned to Jerusalem with great joy” (24:52).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The women find the stone rolled away and the tomb empty. Two men in dazzling clothes say, “Why do you seek the living among the dead? He is not here, but has risen.” They remind the women of what Jesus said in Galilee. The women tell the apostles, but the words seem to them an idle tale, and they do not believe. Peter runs to the tomb, sees the linen cloths, and goes home marveling.

That afternoon, two disciples walk to Emmaus, discussing the events. A stranger joins them, and they do not recognize him. He asks what they are talking about, and they stand still, looking sad. “We had hoped that he was the one to redeem Israel.” Their hope was crushed. The stranger replies, “O foolish ones, and slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have spoken! Was it not necessary that the Christ should suffer these things and enter into his glory?” And “beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself.”

This is the key to reading the whole Bible. All of Scripture, from Moses to the Prophets, points to Christ: his sufferings and his glory. The Old Testament is not a collection of unrelated stories. It is a single story that leads to him. This is the reason the Old Testament is read with the cross in view. At supper, in the breaking of the bread, their eyes were opened and they recognized him, and he vanished. “Did not our hearts burn within us while he talked to us on the road, while he opened to us the Scriptures?” They returned to Jerusalem the same hour.

While they are telling the others, Jesus himself stands among them and says, “Peace to you!” They think he is a ghost, and he shows them his hands and feet and eats a piece of broiled fish. The resurrection was bodily. Then he opens their minds to understand the Scriptures and says that everything written about him in the Law, the Prophets, and the Psalms must be fulfilled. The Christ suffers and rises, and repentance and forgiveness of sins are to be proclaimed in his name to all nations, beginning from Jerusalem. “You are witnesses of these things.” He promises the gift of the Holy Spirit, “the promise of my Father.”

He leads them out to Bethany, lifts up his hands, blesses them, and is carried up into heaven. They worship him and return to Jerusalem with great joy, continually in the temple blessing God. The Gospel that began in the temple with a priest who was struck silent ends in the temple with a people full of praise.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 53 and Psalm 22 are among the passages about the suffering and glory of the Christ. Genesis 3:15, Deuteronomy 18:15, 2 Samuel 7, and Psalm 110 are all part of the testimony. Acts 1:1-11 continues the story. 1 Corinthians 15:3-8 lists the appearances of the risen Christ. John 20:19-29 gives the parallel appearances. 2 Timothy 3:15 says the Scriptures are able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus. Hebrews 1:1-2 says God has spoken by his Son.

STEP 6

Application

Think of an Old Testament passage you have loved, and ask: where does it point to Christ?

When you feel your hopes are crushed, remember that the stranger on the road was alive.

Ask the Lord to open the Scriptures to you, so that your heart burns as you read.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that he is alive, and walks with the discouraged.
- Ask him to open your mind to understand the Scriptures.
- Ask him to make your heart burn as you read.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 91

"And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth."

JOHN 1:14

DAY 633 · WEEK 91

Review and Reflection

Unit 16 review, The New Covenant Inaugurated, Luke

Year 2 · Unit 16 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost."
>
> LUKE 19:10

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this to the crowd that grumbled that he had gone to be the guest of a sinner. Zacchaeus has just given half his goods to the poor, and Jesus replies with his own mission statement.

"For the Son of Man." This is Jesus' favorite title for himself. It comes from Daniel 7, the one who receives dominion from the Ancient of Days, and it also speaks of his humanity. He is the glorious King and the humble servant.

"Came." He came on purpose. Salvation is not a rescue improvised in an emergency. The Son came from the Father with a mission, and Luke has shown it from the manger to the empty tomb.

"To seek." God is the one who seeks. In Luke 15 the shepherd goes after the sheep, the woman searches for the coin, and the father watches the road. Christianity is not a story of humans reaching up for God but of God reaching down. Even our seeking is a response to being sought.

"And to save." The seeking has a purpose, and the purpose is rescue. He came to give his life as a ransom, as he showed on the cross.

"The lost." That is who he seeks. Not the confident or the righteous in their own eyes, but those who know they are lost, like Zacchaeus in his tree, the thief on the cross, the prodigal in the pigsty, and you.

When you feel too far gone, say this verse. You are exactly who he came for.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

You have read the whole Gospel of Luke, and the thread running through it is that salvation is for everyone, including those the world overlooks. It opens with songs: Mary's Magnificat, in which God lifts up the lowly and sends the rich away empty, and Zechariah's Benedictus, which celebrates a God who keeps his covenant. The Savior is born in a manger, announced first to shepherds, and welcomed by Simeon and Anna as a light for the Gentiles. In Nazareth he reads Isaiah 61 and declares that the Scripture is fulfilled in him. He is filled with the Holy Spirit, and he prays at every turning point, before his baptism, before choosing the Twelve, on the mountain, and in the garden. He eats with sinners, honors a centurion's faith, and forgives a woman who loves much. On the road to Jerusalem he teaches the parables found only in Luke: the Good Samaritan, the rich fool, the lost sheep, the lost coin, the lost son, Lazarus, the Pharisee and the tax collector. He meets Zacchaeus and says that he came to seek and save the lost. In Jerusalem he institutes the new covenant in his blood, prays in Gethsemane, is betrayed and denied, declared innocent, and crucified. He forgives his killers, promises paradise to a thief, and commits his spirit to the Father. On the third day he rises and walks with two discouraged disciples, opening to them all the Scriptures concerning himself. The Gospel ends with the commission to preach repentance and forgiveness to all nations, and the promise of the Spirit. Along the way you also prayed Psalms 113, 116, 117, 27, 28, 31, 41, and 55, which gave words to the praise, trust, and betrayal in the story.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does the Magnificat reveal about the kind of salvation God brings?

Reread Luke 1:46-55 and Psalm 113. Notice the reversal of the proud and the lowly, and the link to the promise made to Abraham. Write a few sentences about how this song sets the tone for the whole Gospel.

How does Luke emphasize the role of the Holy Spirit?

Think of the Spirit's presence at John's birth, Mary's conception, Jesus' baptism, the wilderness, Nazareth, and the promise of the Father in chapter 24. What difference does the Spirit make in Jesus' life, and what does he promise for his followers?

What does Luke's emphasis on prayer teach us about Jesus' own spiritual life?

Recall the times Jesus prayed: at his baptism, before choosing the Twelve, in desolate places, on the mountain, in Gethsemane, and on the cross. Pick one and describe what it shows about his dependence on the Father and what it means for your own prayer.

How does the road to Emmaus teach us how to read the whole Bible?

Reread Luke 24:25-27 and 24:44-47. Jesus says that Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms are about him. Name one Old Testament passage from this plan that you now read differently because of this, and explain how it points to Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for sending his Son to seek and save the lost, and for finding you.

Tell him what you have seen in Jesus through Luke.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 17 · DAYS 634-665

The New Covenant Inaugurated: John

John 1-21

The Word became flesh. Union with Christ, eternal life, and the Spirit's coming.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life."

JOHN 3:16

Light (36, 43), the shepherd (23), and God's nearness (139, 100, 103) beside John.

UNIT 17

In this unit

WEEK 91

634	John 1:1-51	*Reading*
635	John 1:1-18; Philippians 2:5-11; Colossians 1:15-20	*Doctrine*
636	John 2:1-3:36	*Reading*
637	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 92

638	John 3:1-21; Ezekiel 36:25-27; Titus 3:3-7	*Doctrine*
639	Psalm 36	*Psalm*
640	Psalm 139:1-18	*Psalm*
641	John 4:1-54	*Reading*
642	John 4:19-26; Psalm 95; Hebrews 12:18-29	*Doctrine*
643	John 5:1-47	*Reading*
644	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 93

645	John 6:1-71	*Reading*
646	John 7:1-8:11	*Reading*
647	John 8:12-59	*Reading*
648	Psalm 119:97-120	*Psalm*
649	Psalm 43	*Psalm*
650	John 9:1-10:21	*Reading*
651	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 94

652	John 10:22-11:57	*Reading*
653	John 12:1-50	*Reading*
654	John 13:1-14:31	*Reading*
655	Psalm 23	*Psalm*

656	Psalm 100	*Psalm*
657	Psalm 103	*Psalm*
658	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 95

659	John 15:1-16:33	*Reading*
660	John 17:1-26	*Reading*
661	John 18:1-19:16	*Reading*
662	John 19:17-42	*Reading*
663	John 20:1-21:25	*Reading*
664	Review and Reflection	*Review*
665	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 634 · WEEK 91

John 1:1-51

The Word made flesh; the first disciples, "come and see"

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 1:1-51. John begins before creation, with the Word, then moves to John the Baptist, the first disciples, and Nathanael. Read verses 1-18 slowly, as the prologue to the whole Gospel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

John was one of the Twelve, the disciple whom Jesus loved, and he wrote this Gospel late in his life. He tells us his purpose near the end: that we may believe Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and have life in his name. His Gospel is different from Matthew, Mark, and Luke. It contains very little of the parables and much more of Jesus' long conversations, and it is built around seven signs and seven "I AM" statements. It begins with a hymn that takes us back to the beginning of everything.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God" (1:1).
2. "The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it" (1:5).
3. "But to all who did receive him, who believed in his name, he gave the right to become children of God" (1:12).
4. "And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth" (1:14).
5. "No one has ever seen God; the only God, who is at the Father's side, he has made him known" (1:18).

6. “Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!” (1:29).
7. “Philip said to him, Come and see” (1:46).
8. “You will see heaven opened, and the angels of God ascending and descending on the Son of Man” (1:51).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Gospel opens with the words of Genesis 1:1, “In the beginning.” But now the focus is not on creation but on the one through whom it came. The Word was with God (distinct from the Father) and the Word was God (fully divine). He was in the beginning, so he is eternal. “All things were made through him,” so he is Creator. In him was life, and that life was the light of men.

Then John says that the light shines in the darkness and the darkness has not overcome it. He introduces John the Baptist, a witness who points to the light. The true light came into the world, yet the world did not know him, and his own people did not receive him. But to those who did receive him, he gave the right to become children of God, born not of blood or the will of the flesh but of God. That promise is the core of the Gospel.

Verse 14 is the center of the prologue: “The Word became flesh and dwelt among us.” The word for dwelt means pitched his tent, an echo of the tabernacle in the wilderness. God has come to live with his people in a person. “We have seen his glory,” says John, “full of grace and truth,” which recalls the LORD’s self-revelation to Moses in Exodus 34. The law was given through Moses, but grace and truth came through Jesus Christ. No one has seen God, but the Son has made him known.

The rest of the chapter is a parade of titles. John the Baptist points to Jesus: “Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!” Andrew finds Peter, saying, “We have found the Messiah.” Philip finds Nathanael, who doubts that anything good could come from Nazareth, and Philip answers with an invitation: “Come and see.” Jesus tells Nathanael that he saw him under the fig tree, and Nathanael confesses, “You are the Son of God! You are the King of Israel!” Jesus promises he will see greater things: heaven opened and angels ascending and descending on the Son of Man, an echo of Jacob’s ladder at Bethel. Jesus himself is the meeting place between heaven and earth.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:1-3 is the beginning John echoes. Proverbs 8:22-31 speaks of wisdom beside God at creation. Exodus 25:8 and 33:18-23 are about God dwelling with his people and showing his glory. Exodus 34:6 is the source of “grace and truth.” Isaiah 53:7 is the Lamb. Genesis 28:12 is

Jacob's ladder. Hebrews 1:1-3 states that the Son is the radiance of the glory of God. 1 John 1:1-4 is John's own testimony to what he saw and touched.

STEP 6

Application

Read John 1:1-18 aloud three times. Which phrase strikes you most? Write it down.

Take Philip's invitation, "Come and see," and ask yourself who you could invite to see Jesus.

Praise Jesus today as Creator, as the light in darkness, and as the Lamb who takes away sin.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for becoming flesh and making his dwelling among us.

Tell him, "I'll come and see," and ask him to show you more.

Ask him to give you the right to be his child.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 91

"And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth."

JOHN 1:14

DAY 635 · WEEK 91

John 1:1-18; Philippians 2:5-11; Colossians 1:15-20

The Person of Christ, Incarnation

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 1:1-18, Philippians 2:5-11, and Colossians 1:15-20. Today is a doctrinal pause on the person of Christ: who he is, and what it means that the Word became flesh. Notice what each passage says about his divinity and his humanity.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Three of the greatest passages about Christ in the New Testament come from two authors. John writes a prologue to his Gospel. Paul, writing from prison to the Philippians, quotes what is probably an early hymn. In Colossians, he answers a church troubled by false teaching and puts Christ above all. The church has summarized these teachings in the doctrine of the incarnation: that the eternal Son took on a true human nature without ceasing to be God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God” (John 1:1).
2. “And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us” (John 1:14).
3. “Who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped” (Philippians 2:6).
4. “But emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men” (Philippians 2:7).

5. “And being found in human form, he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross” (Philippians 2:8).
6. “And every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father” (Philippians 2:11).
7. “He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation” (Colossians 1:15).
8. “For in him all the fullness of God was pleased to dwell” (Colossians 1:19).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The incarnation is the central miracle of the Christian faith: the eternal Son of God, the second person of the Trinity, took to himself a true human nature, with a body and a soul, and was born of the virgin Mary. He did not stop being God; he added humanity. The church confessed at Chalcedon in AD 451 that Christ is one person in two natures, fully God and fully man, “without confusion, without change, without division, without separation.” Christians have long held this because the Scriptures teach both halves. Jesus is called God, worshiped, and credited with creating all things. And he hungers, thirsts, weeps, grows weary, suffers, and dies. If he were not truly God, he could not save us. If he were not truly man, he could not stand in our place. “Emptied himself” in Philippians 2 does not mean he gave up his divine nature, but that he laid aside the privileges of glory and took the form of a servant. The incarnation is the beginning of his work of redemption: the one who became what we are, so that we might become what he is, children of God.

STEP 4

Interpretation

John tells us who the Word is. He was with God and was God, the agent of creation, the source of life and light. Then comes the most astonishing sentence of the Bible: “The Word became flesh.” The one who made the world entered it. Notice that John does not say the Word “appeared” to be flesh or “entered” a body. He became flesh. He took our nature and lived among us.

Paul gives the path of the incarnation in Philippians 2. Christ Jesus was in the form of God, and did not treat equality with God as something to hold on to. He emptied himself, taking the form of a servant. He humbled himself, became obedient, and went all the way to death on a cross. Therefore God has highly exalted him and given him the name above every name, “that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow.” The pattern is descent and ascent. Paul’s reason for telling the story is practical: “Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus.” The incarnation is also a model for humility.

In Colossians, Paul speaks of the cosmic Christ. He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation, which means supreme in rank and not first created, for "by him all things were created." He holds all things together. He is the head of the church, the firstborn from the dead. All the fullness of God dwells in him, and through him God reconciles all things to himself, making peace by the blood of his cross.

Put these three together. The one who made the stars became a baby. The one who holds the universe together was carried by his mother. The one who is Lord of all died on a cross. This is why the church has always been amazed. Our salvation depends on who he is.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 9:6 calls the child "Mighty God." Isaiah 45:23 is the verse Paul uses in Philippians 2:10-11. Hebrews 1:1-4 and 2:14-18 speak of the Son's deity and humanity. 1 Timothy 3:16 calls it a great mystery. 1 John 4:2 says every spirit that confesses that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is from God. Galatians 4:4 says God sent his Son, born of woman. Luke 1:35 says the child will be called holy, the Son of God.

STEP 6

Application

Say the Chalcedonian summary aloud: Jesus is fully God and fully man, one person. Thank him for each half.

Read Philippians 2:5 again. Where is Christ calling you to take the form of a servant?

When you feel that God is far away, remember that the Word became flesh and dwelt among us.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship Jesus, the Word who was with God and was God.
- Thank him for emptying himself and taking the form of a servant.
- Tell him what it means that he became one of us.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 91

“And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth.”

JOHN 1:14

DAY 636 · WEEK 91

John 2:1-3:36

Cana; Temple cleansing; Nicodemus, born again

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 2:1-3:36. Jesus turns water into wine at Cana, cleanses the temple, and talks with Nicodemus at night. John the Baptist then speaks of Jesus' increase. Notice that John calls miracles "signs," pointing to something beyond themselves.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

John does not record Jesus' birth or temptation. After the prologue and the first disciples, he moves to a wedding in Cana of Galilee. Jesus' first sign is there. Then he goes to Jerusalem for Passover, clears the temple, and meets a ruler of the Jews, Nicodemus, who comes by night. John 3:16 comes from this conversation and has been called the gospel in a sentence. It is also the anchor verse of this unit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Do whatever he tells you" (2:5).
2. "This, the first of his signs, Jesus did at Cana in Galilee, and manifested his glory. And his disciples believed in him" (2:11).
3. "Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up" (2:19).
4. "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God" (3:3).
5. "The wind blows where it wishes, and you hear its sound, but you do not know where it comes from or where it goes. So it is with everyone who is born of the Spirit" (3:8).
6. "For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life" (3:16).

7. “He must increase, but I must decrease” (3:30).
8. “Whoever believes in the Son has eternal life; whoever does not obey the Son shall not see life, but the wrath of God remains on him” (3:36).

STEP 4

Interpretation

At the wedding in Cana, the wine runs out, a serious embarrassment. Mary tells Jesus, and then tells the servants, “Do whatever he tells you.” Jesus has them fill six stone jars, used for Jewish purification, with water, and the water becomes wine, better than what was served before. John says this was the first of Jesus’ signs and “manifested his glory.” The abundance of wine, perhaps 120 to 180 gallons, points to the messianic age, which the prophets described as a feast of wine. The old purification is replaced by the new joy.

In Jerusalem, Jesus drives out the sellers from the temple. When asked for a sign, he says, “Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up.” John explains that he was speaking about the temple of his body. Jesus is the true place where God and man meet, and he will rise on the third day.

Nicodemus, a Pharisee and a member of the council, comes at night. He recognizes that Jesus is a teacher from God. Jesus replies abruptly: “Unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God.” Nicodemus is puzzled. How can anyone enter the womb a second time? Jesus explains that one must be born of water and the Spirit. The Spirit, like the wind, is sovereign and invisible but his work can be seen. A teacher of Israel should have known this from Ezekiel 36. Jesus then says that as Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, so the Son of Man must be lifted up, that whoever believes in him may have eternal life.

Then comes verse 16. God’s love is the source. The world is the object, the whole sinful world. The gift is his only Son. The condition is belief, and the result is that we do not perish but have eternal life. The next verse says God did not send his Son to condemn the world, but that the world might be saved through him.

The chapter closes with John the Baptist, who rejoices that Jesus is gaining followers. He is the friend of the bridegroom. “He must increase, but I must decrease.” The one who comes from above is above all. And verse 36 sets the choice before everyone: believe and live, or reject and remain under wrath.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 25:6 and Amos 9:13-14 promise abundant wine in the age to come. Psalm 69:9 is the zeal for the house that the disciples recall. Malachi 3:1 promises that the Lord will suddenly come to his temple. Ezekiel 36:25-27 describes the cleansing and the new heart. Numbers 21:4-9 is the bronze serpent. Romans 5:8 and 1 John 4:9-10 echo God's love in giving his Son. Ephesians 2:8-9 says we are saved by grace through faith.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize John 3:16 this week. It is the memory verse for the unit.

Say "He must increase, but I must decrease" as a prayer at the start of your day.

Think of a Nicodemus in your life, a thoughtful person with questions, and pray for them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for revealing his glory.
- Thank him for the new birth, and ask him to keep working in you.
- Tell him you believe, and ask him to deepen it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 91

"And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth."

JOHN 1:14

DAY 637 · WEEK 91

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read John 1:14 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth."

JOHN 1:14

REST

Meditation

This single verse is the heart of the Christmas message, and of the whole Gospel of John.

"The Word." In Greek, logos. To Greek readers, it was the rational order behind the universe. To Jewish readers, it was God's creative and revealing speech. John says that this Word is a person, the eternal Son who was with God and was God.

"Became flesh." Flesh means our weak, mortal humanity. He did not hover above it. He took it on. The infinite entered the finite, and the Creator became a creature.

"And dwelt among us." The verb is "tabernacled." Just as God's glory filled the tent in the wilderness, so God's glory now lives in a human body. God has pitched his tent in our neighborhood.

"We have seen his glory." John is a witness. He saw the glory on the mountain, at Cana, and at the cross. It was a glory of weakness as well as power.

“Full of grace and truth.” Grace is God’s free favor. Truth is God’s faithfulness and reality. In Christ we get both.

When you wonder what God is like, say this verse. Look at Jesus.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the Gospel of Luke, with the cross, the thief’s prayer, the empty tomb, and the walk to Emmaus, where Jesus opened the Scriptures and showed that they are about him. Then you began the Gospel of John. The prologue told you that the Word who was with God and was God became flesh and dwelt among us. Your doctrinal pause on the incarnation set John’s words beside Philippians 2 and Colossians 1: the one who made all things emptied himself, became a servant, and died on a cross. In John 2 and 3 you saw Jesus turn water into wine, cleanse the temple, and tell Nicodemus that he must be born again. You met the verse that sums up the Gospel: “For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son.”

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

John says the Word became flesh and dwelt among us. What does it mean for you that God chose to live among us as a human being?

Jesus’ first sign was turning water into wine, a picture of the joy of the new covenant. How does Jesus bring joy where there was only emptiness?

Nicodemus came by night with questions. What is one honest question you would bring to Jesus right now?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for dwelling among us, full of grace and truth.

Thank him for new birth.

Rest in him.

DAY 638 · WEEK 92

John 3:1-21; Ezekiel 36:25-27; Titus 3:3-7

Regeneration and the New Birth

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 3:1-21, Ezekiel 36:25-27, and Titus 3:3-7. Today is a doctrinal pause on regeneration, the new birth. Notice who does the work in each passage.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus told Nicodemus that a person must be born again. Nicodemus, a teacher of Israel, was confused, and Jesus replied that he should have understood. The promise of a new heart is found in the prophets, especially Ezekiel. In Titus, Paul speaks of the same event in the life of the believer: the washing of regeneration. The doctrine of regeneration is the teaching that God, by his Spirit, gives new spiritual life to those who were dead in sin.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God” (John 3:3).
2. “Unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God” (John 3:5).
3. “That which is born of the flesh is flesh, and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit” (John 3:6).
4. “I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you shall be clean from all your uncleannesses” (Ezekiel 36:25).
5. “And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you” (Ezekiel 36:26).

6. “And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh” (Ezekiel 36:26).

7. “And I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes” (Ezekiel 36:27).

8. “He saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit” (Titus 3:5).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Regeneration is the act of God by which he gives new spiritual life to a person who was dead in sin. It is the beginning of the Christian life. Jesus calls it being born again or born from above. The Bible teaches that we are born spiritually dead (Ephesians 2:1) and cannot save ourselves. God makes us alive. In the language of Ezekiel, he replaces a heart of stone with a heart of flesh and puts his Spirit within us. As in physical birth, the one being born does not bring about the birth: it is a work of God, “not of the will of man, but of God” (John 1:13). Reformed Christians have generally taught that regeneration comes first in order and produces the faith and repentance by which we respond to the gospel. Other evangelicals place regeneration and faith more closely together, but all agree that salvation is the Spirit’s gift and that those who are born again will show it in a new love for God, new obedience, and perseverance. It is not something we achieve. It is something we receive.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus’ words to Nicodemus show how radical the need is. A morally serious, religious man needs not improvement but new birth. “That which is born of the flesh is flesh.” Human nature cannot produce spiritual life. Only “that which is born of the Spirit is spirit.” Then Jesus compares the Spirit to the wind. You cannot control it, and you cannot predict it, but you can see its effects. The new birth is God’s sovereign work.

The Old Testament had promised it. Ezekiel 36 speaks of a day when God would gather his people, cleanse them with water, give them a new heart, and put his Spirit within them so that they would walk in his ways. This is the new covenant promise, along with Jeremiah 31. When Jesus mentions water and the Spirit, Nicodemus should have thought of this passage. The problem under the old covenant was a heart of stone, a will that would not obey. The solution is not better instruction but a new heart.

Paul says the same in Titus 3. He describes our past: foolish, disobedient, led astray, slaves to passions, hated and hating. Then “the goodness and loving kindness of God our Savior appeared.” He saved us not because of works but according to his own mercy, “by the

washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit, whom he poured out on us richly through Jesus Christ our Savior." Regeneration is purely a gift, and the result is that we become heirs with the hope of eternal life.

The doctrine comforts and humbles. It humbles because we contributed nothing to our new life. It comforts because the one who began it will finish it. And it presses us to look for the signs of life in ourselves, such as love for Christ, hatred of sin, and a desire to obey, and to pray for those who are dead in sin that God would make them alive.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 31:33 and Ezekiel 11:19-20 also promise a new heart. Deuteronomy 30:6 speaks of the circumcision of the heart. Ephesians 2:1-5 says we were dead in trespasses and God made us alive with Christ. 1 Peter 1:3 and 1:23 speak of being born again. 2 Corinthians 5:17 says anyone in Christ is a new creation. John 1:12-13 says we are born of God. 1 John 3:9 and 5:1 describe those who are born of God.

STEP 6

Application

Look for evidence of the Spirit's work in you: love for God, sorrow for sin, hunger for the Word. Thank God for each.

Pray by name for someone who seems far from God. Ask God to give them a new heart.

Read Ezekiel 36:25-27 as a prayer, in the first person: "Give me a new heart and put your Spirit in me."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for making you alive when you were dead in sin.

Thank him for the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Spirit.

Ask him to show you where new life is evident in you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 92

“God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth.”

JOHN 4:24

DAY 639 · WEEK 92

Psalm 36

Steadfast love extends to the heavens, the fountain of life

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 36. It sets the darkness of the wicked heart beside the vast steadfast love of God, and it ends with the fountain of life. Read verses 5 to 9 aloud.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 36 is a psalm of David, "the servant of the LORD." It begins with a picture of the wicked person, then turns sharply to the character of God. At the center is the fountain of life: "In your light do we see light." It sits well beside John, which says the true light has come into the world and that in him was life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Transgression speaks to the wicked deep in his heart; there is no fear of God before his eyes" (v. 1).
2. "Your steadfast love, O LORD, extends to the heavens, your faithfulness to the clouds" (v. 5).
3. "Your righteousness is like the mountains of God; your judgments are like the great deep" (v. 6).
4. "How precious is your steadfast love, O God! The children of mankind take refuge in the shadow of your wings" (v. 7).
5. "They feast on the abundance of your house, and you give them drink from the river of your delights" (v. 8).
6. "For with you is the fountain of life; in your light do we see light" (v. 9).

7. “Oh, continue your steadfast love to those who know you, and your righteousness to the upright of heart!” (v. 10).

8. “There the evildoers lie fallen; they are thrust down, unable to rise” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts in a dark place, the heart of the wicked. Sin whispers to him, and he has no fear of God. He flatters himself, so that he does not see his guilt. His words are trouble and deceit, he plots evil on his bed, and he does not reject what is wrong. The root of wickedness is forgetting God.

Then verse 5 begins with a sudden shift, like a sunrise: “Your steadfast love, O LORD, extends to the heavens.” The contrast could not be greater. The wicked heart is small and self-absorbed. God’s love reaches the sky. His faithfulness reaches the clouds. His righteousness is like the highest mountains, and his judgments are like the deepest sea. He cares for people and animals alike.

“How precious is your steadfast love, O God!” It is precious because it is a refuge: “The children of mankind take refuge in the shadow of your wings.” The image is of a bird sheltering its young. They feast on the abundance of God’s house, and he gives them drink from the river of his delights, an image drawn from Eden, whose river watered the garden.

Verse 9 is the heart: “For with you is the fountain of life; in your light do we see light.” Life is not something we have in ourselves. It flows from God. And we do not see truth by our own light but by his. Only in the light of God can we see anything rightly.

In John’s Gospel, Jesus is the fountain of life and the light. “In him was life, and the life was the light of men.” He told the woman at the well that he would give living water, and on the last day of the feast he cried, “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink.” The psalmist’s longing is answered in Christ. The psalm ends with a prayer for continued love and protection, and with the wicked fallen, unable to rise.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 2:10 describes the river of Eden. Psalm 17:8 and 57:1 use the shadow of wings. Psalm 46:4 speaks of the river whose streams make glad the city of God. Jeremiah 2:13 says Israel forsook the fountain of living waters. John 1:4, 4:14, 7:37-38, and 8:12 apply this imagery to Jesus. Revelation 22:1-5 describes the river of life and the light of God himself.

STEP 6

Application

Say verse 9 aloud and ask, “Where am I looking for life apart from God?”

Meditate on the size of God’s love: the heavens, the clouds, the mountains, the deep.

Take refuge under his wings. Name one worry and bring it to him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for his steadfast love that reaches the heavens.
- Tell him what it means to take refuge in the shadow of his wings.
- Thank him for the fountain of life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 92

“God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth.”

JOHN 4:24

DAY 640 · WEEK 92

Psalm 139:1-18

O LORD, you have searched me and known me

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 139:1-18. David marvels that God knows him completely. Notice how the psalm moves from knowing to presence to creation to wonder.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 139 is one of the most personal psalms. David reflects on the fact that God knows everything about him, is present everywhere, and made him in the womb. The last verses (19 to 24) turn to a prayer against the wicked and a prayer to be searched, but today's reading covers the first eighteen verses, the part that has comforted many. It follows the Psalm 36 theme of God's vast care.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, you have searched me and known me!" (v. 1).
2. "You know when I sit down and when I rise up; you discern my thoughts from afar" (v. 2).
3. "Even before a word is on my tongue, behold, O LORD, you know it altogether" (v. 4).
4. "Where shall I go from your Spirit? Or where shall I flee from your presence?" (v. 7).
5. "For you formed my inward parts; you knitted me together in my mother's womb" (v. 13).
6. "I praise you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Wonderful are your works; my soul knows it very well" (v. 14).
7. "Your eyes saw my unformed substance; in your book were written, every one of them, the days that were formed for me, when as yet there was none of them" (v. 16).

8 “How precious to me are your thoughts, O God! How vast is the sum of them!” (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with complete knowledge. God has searched David and known him. He knows when David sits and stands, knows his thoughts from far off, and knows his words before he speaks them. He hems David in, behind and before, and lays his hand on him. David’s response: “Such knowledge is too wonderful for me; it is high; I cannot attain it.”

This could feel threatening, to be known so completely. But for David it is a comfort. The question in verses 7 to 12 shows that he has considered escape and found that there is none. “Where shall I go from your Spirit?” If he goes up to heaven, God is there. If he makes his bed in Sheol, God is there. If he takes the wings of the morning and dwells in the uttermost parts of the sea, even there God’s hand will lead him. Even darkness is not dark to God. The presence of God, which could be terrifying for a sinner, is a source of safety for a child.

Then the psalm goes back before birth. God formed his inward parts and knitted him together in his mother’s womb. “I praise you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made.” This is a deep affirmation of the value of every human being. Each of us is a work of God, planned and watched over from the beginning. In his book were written all the days that were formed for us, before any of them existed. Our lives are known to God and held by him.

And David’s response is awe: “How precious to me are your thoughts, O God! How vast is the sum of them! If I would count them, they are more than the sand.” When I awake, he says, I am still with you.

In John, Jesus is shown to know people completely. He knows Nathanael under the fig tree and the Samaritan woman’s history. To be known by him is to be known by God, and to be loved.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 1:5 says God knew the prophet before he formed him in the womb. Job 10:8-12 and Psalm 119:73 also speak of God’s making. Proverbs 15:3 says the eyes of the LORD are in every place. John 1:47-49 and 4:16-19 show Jesus knowing people. Hebrews 4:13 says no creature is hidden from his sight. Matthew 10:29-31 says the very hairs of your head are numbered. Ephesians 2:10 says we are his workmanship.

STEP 6

Application

Read verses 1 to 6 slowly, and let yourself be fully known. Is that comforting or uncomfortable? Tell God.

Thank God for how he made you, including the parts you struggle to accept.

Share Psalm 139:13-14 with someone who feels worthless.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he has searched you and knows you.

Tell him what you want him to see in you today.

Praise him that you are fearfully and wonderfully made.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 92

"God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth."

JOHN 4:24

DAY 641 · WEEK 92

John 4:1-54

The Samaritan woman; living water; the official's son

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 4:1-54. Jesus meets a Samaritan woman at a well, offers her living water, and many in her town believe. He then heals an official's son from a distance. Notice who Jesus talks to and what he offers.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus leaves Judea and goes north to Galilee, taking the road through Samaria, which most Jews avoided because of centuries of hostility. At noon he sits by Jacob's well, tired, while his disciples go to buy food. A woman comes to draw water at a time when no one else would be there. Jews and Samaritans did not share dishes, and a rabbi did not usually speak with a woman in public. Jesus breaks every barrier.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give me a drink" (4:7).
2. "If you knew the gift of God, and who it is that is saying to you, Give me a drink, you would have asked him, and he would have given you living water" (4:10).
3. "The water that I will give him will become in him a spring of water welling up to eternal life" (4:14).
4. "Come, see a man who told me all that I ever did. Can this be the Christ?" (4:29).
5. "I who speak to you am he" (4:26).
6. "My food is to do the will of him who sent me and to accomplish his work" (4:34).
7. "We have heard for ourselves, and we know that this is indeed the Savior of the world" (4:42).

8 “Go; your son will live” (4:50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus asks a Samaritan woman for a drink. The request surprises her. Then he turns it around: if she knew who was asking, she would ask him for living water. She thinks he means running water, but he is speaking of the Spirit, a spring welling up in a person to eternal life. The woman asks for it, perhaps still half joking, and Jesus says, “Go, call your husband.” She has had five husbands, and the man she lives with now is not her husband. Jesus knows her whole story, and he does not shrink from it. His aim is not to shame her but to bring her to the truth.

She changes the subject to the old argument over where to worship. Jesus tells her that the hour is coming, and is now here, when true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth. We will return to this in the doctrinal pause. Then she says, “I know that Messiah is coming,” and Jesus says, “I who speak to you am he.” This is the first time in the Gospel that Jesus openly says he is the Messiah, and he says it to a Samaritan woman with a past.

She leaves her water jar and goes to the town, saying, “Come, see a man who told me all that I ever did. Can this be the Christ?” She is the first evangelist in John, and her witness is simple. Many Samaritans believe because of her word, and then they invite Jesus to stay two days. Then many more believe, and they say, “We know that this is indeed the Savior of the world.” The Gospel crosses the boundary of ethnicity.

Meanwhile the disciples are puzzled that Jesus has no need of food. He says, “My food is to do the will of him who sent me.” He points to the fields white for harvest.

Back in Cana, an official comes from Capernaum begging Jesus to heal his dying son. Jesus says, “Go; your son will live.” The man believes the word and goes, and finds that the fever left at the very hour. This is the second sign. Faith takes Jesus at his word.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 29:1-12, Exodus 2:15-21, and Genesis 24 are Old Testament wells where significant meetings happen. Isaiah 12:3 and 55:1 promise water for the thirsty. Jeremiah 2:13 speaks of the fountain of living water. Ezekiel 47:1-12 pictures a river flowing from the temple. John 7:37-39 explains that the living water is the Spirit. Acts 8:4-25 records the gospel’s spread to Samaria. Revelation 21:6 and 22:17 offer the water of life freely.

STEP 6

Application

Think about what you drink from to satisfy your thirst, such as approval, success, or comfort. Bring it to Jesus.

Like the woman, tell someone simply what Jesus has done in your life.

Who is the Samaritan in your life, a person it would be awkward to talk to about Jesus? Ask God for a chance.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus that he knows everything about you, and let that be good news.
- Ask him for living water.
- Ask him to teach you to tell others about him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 92

"God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth."

JOHN 4:24

DAY 642 · WEEK 92

John 4:19-26; Psalm 95; Hebrews 12:18-29

Worship

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 4:19-26, Psalm 95, and Hebrews 12:18-29. Today is a doctrinal pause on worship. Notice who is worshiped, how, and why.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Samaritan woman asked Jesus where one should worship, on Mount Gerizim or in Jerusalem. Jesus answered with a statement about worship that changes everything. Psalm 95 is one of the great invitations to worship in the Psalter, and Hebrews 12 describes the nature of worship under the new covenant. Together they teach that worship is the purpose for which we were made, and that it is directed to the Father, through the Son, in the Spirit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Woman, believe me, the hour is coming when neither on this mountain nor in Jerusalem will you worship the Father” (John 4:21).
2. “The hour is coming, and is now here, when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth, for the Father is seeking such people to worship him” (John 4:23).
3. “God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth” (John 4:24).
4. “Oh come, let us sing to the LORD; let us make a joyful noise to the rock of our salvation!” (Psalm 95:1).
5. “Oh come, let us worship and bow down; let us kneel before the LORD, our Maker!” (Psalm 95:6).

6. “For he is our God, and we are the people of his pasture, and the sheep of his hand” (Psalm 95:7).
7. “Therefore let us be grateful for receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken, and thus let us offer to God acceptable worship, with reverence and awe” (Hebrews 12:28).
8. “For our God is a consuming fire” (Hebrews 12:29).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Worship is the response of the whole person to the worth of God. It is what we were made for. In the Bible, true worship has three marks. First, it is directed to the right object: the triune God alone, not any idol, whether carved or imagined. Second, it is offered “in spirit and truth.” Jesus does not abolish outward forms, but he insists that worship be from the heart, by the Spirit, and according to the truth that God has revealed in Christ and in his Word. Third, it is offered through Christ, our mediator. Under the old covenant, worship centered on the temple, the priests, and the sacrifices. Now Jesus is the temple, the priest, and the sacrifice, and we draw near through him. The Reformed tradition has taught that God is to be worshiped as he commands in Scripture, and so gathered worship centers on the reading and preaching of the Word, prayer, singing, and the sacraments. Worship is also all of life: Romans 12:1 calls us to present our bodies as a living sacrifice. It is joyful and reverent at once, for God is both our Father and a consuming fire.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Samaritan woman raises a question of place. Jesus says the place no longer matters. A new era is beginning in which worship is not tied to a mountain or a building. The reason is that the Father is seeking worshipers, and God is spirit. He cannot be confined to a location. “In spirit” means by the Holy Spirit, who makes the heart alive. “In truth” means according to the reality revealed in Christ, who is the truth.

Psalm 95 gives a picture of what worship looks like. It begins with singing and a joyful noise, because the LORD is a great God and a great King above all gods, who holds the depths of the earth and the heights of the mountains, and made the sea and dry land. Then it moves from joy to reverence: “Let us worship and bow down; let us kneel.” We worship because he is our Maker, and our shepherd, and we are the sheep of his hand. Then the psalm ends with a warning not to harden our hearts as Israel did in the wilderness. Worship requires listening: “Today, if you hear his voice.”

Hebrews 12 contrasts Sinai and Zion. Israel came to a mountain of fire, darkness, and trembling, and begged that no further word be spoken. But believers have come to Mount Zion, to the heavenly Jerusalem, to innumerable angels, to the assembly of the firstborn, to God the judge, and "to Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant, and to the sprinkled blood." We receive a kingdom that cannot be shaken. Therefore we offer acceptable worship "with reverence and awe, for our God is a consuming fire."

True worship holds both together: the intimacy of a child with his Father and the awe of a creature before the Holy One.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 12 and 1 Kings 8 deal with the place of worship under the old covenant. Isaiah 66:1-2 says heaven is God's throne, and he looks to the humble. Psalm 29:2 says to worship the LORD in the splendor of holiness. Romans 12:1-2 calls for living sacrifice. Philippians 3:3 describes those who worship by the Spirit of God. Revelation 4 and 5 show worship in heaven. Hebrews 10:19-22 invites us to draw near.

STEP 6

Application

Prepare for worship this Sunday: pray, rest well, and arrive ready to listen.

Take one thing you do this week, such as work, and offer it as worship.

Sing Psalm 95 or a hymn to God in private, even if you're not a singer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to worship in spirit and truth.

Ask him to teach you to worship even when you do not feel like it.

Praise him as the great God and great King.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 92

“God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth.”

JOHN 4:24

DAY 643 · WEEK 92

John 5:1-47

Healing at Bethesda; the Son's authority; witnesses to Jesus

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 5:1-47. Jesus heals a man at the pool of Bethesda on the Sabbath, and the leaders want to kill him. He then speaks at length about his relationship to the Father. Notice the claims he makes.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus returns to Jerusalem for a feast. At the pool of Bethesda, many sick people lie waiting for healing. One man has been ill for thirty-eight years. Jesus heals him, and since it is the Sabbath, the leaders object. What follows is one of the longest and most direct claims to deity in the Gospels. Jesus makes himself equal to the Father in work, honor, and authority, and then lists the witnesses to his claim.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Do you want to be healed?" (5:6).
2. "Get up, take up your bed, and walk" (5:8).
3. "My Father is working until now, and I am working" (5:17).
4. "Calling God his own Father, making himself equal with God" (5:18).
5. "Whoever hears my word and believes him who sent me has eternal life. He does not come into judgment, but has passed from death to life" (5:24).
6. "The hour is coming, and is now here, when the dead will hear the voice of the Son of God, and those who hear will live" (5:25).
7. "You search the Scriptures because you think that in them you have eternal life; and it is they that bear witness about me" (5:39).

8 “For if you believed Moses, you would believe me; for he wrote of me” (5:46).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The man by the pool is helpless. He has no one to put him in the water. Jesus asks, “Do you want to be healed?” and instead of answering yes, the man gives an excuse. Jesus does not need his help. He says, “Get up, take up your bed, and walk,” and the man is healed at once. The man did nothing to earn it. This is grace.

The leaders do not rejoice. The healing was on the Sabbath, and the man is carrying his mat. When they persecute Jesus, he answers, “My Father is working until now, and I am working.” God does not stop working on the Sabbath, because he sustains the world and upholds the lives of his creatures. Jesus claims the same prerogative. The leaders understand perfectly: he is “making himself equal with God,” and they seek to kill him.

Jesus does not retreat. He doubles down. The Son does only what he sees the Father doing. The Father shows him everything. Like the Father, he raises the dead and gives life to whom he will. The Father has given all judgment to the Son, “that all may honor the Son, just as they honor the Father.” Whoever does not honor the Son does not honor the Father. And then, a promise: “Whoever hears my word and believes him who sent me has eternal life. He does not come into judgment, but has passed from death to life.” Eternal life is not only future. Believers have already passed from death to life.

Jesus then lists witnesses: John the Baptist, the works he does, the Father himself, and the Scriptures. The leaders search the Scriptures, thinking they give life, but they refuse to come to him. The Scriptures are not an end in themselves. They point to him. “Moses wrote of me.” It is possible to study the Bible diligently and still miss its center. The leaders are an example of how not to read, and Jesus teaches us to read the Scriptures to find Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 20:8-11 and Deuteronomy 5:12-15 give the Sabbath commandment. Isaiah 40:28 says God does not grow weary. Daniel 7:13-14 gives the Son of Man authority. Daniel 12:2 speaks of the resurrection of the dead. Deuteronomy 18:15-19 promises a prophet like Moses. Luke 24:27 and 24:44 say the Scriptures speak of Christ. Romans 5:1 and 8:1 say there is now no condemnation. Ephesians 2:4-5 says we are made alive.

STEP 6

Application

Answer Jesus’ question honestly: do you want to be healed? Where do you make excuses?

When you read the Bible, ask: where does this point to Jesus?

Thank God that you have passed from death to life. Say it aloud.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell Jesus you are helpless, and let him ask whether you want to be healed.

Thank him that he heals by his word alone.

Ask him to give you life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 92

"God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth."

JOHN 4:24

DAY 644 · WEEK 92

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read John 4:24 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth."

JOHN 4:24

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this to a Samaritan woman, in answer to her question about where worship should take place. It is among the most important sentences in the Bible on worship.

"God is spirit." God is not a physical being, limited to a place or an image. He is invisible, everywhere present, and alive. That is why Israel was forbidden to make images, and why he cannot be confined to a mountain or a building.

"And those who worship him." Worship is not optional or peripheral. It is the reason we exist. The Father is seeking worshipers. He is not indifferent to whether we come.

"Must worship in spirit." This means with the heart, through the Holy Spirit, who gives us new life. Worship that is only outward ritual is empty. Worship in spirit comes from the inside.

“And truth.” Worship must be shaped by what God has actually revealed. It is not whatever feels sincere. Jesus himself is the truth, and the Scriptures are the truth about him.

When you feel that your worship is dull, or you do not know how to come to God, say this verse. The Father is seeking you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you studied the new birth. In the doctrinal pause on regeneration, you saw that being born again is God’s work, promised in Ezekiel 36 and described in Titus 3 as the washing of regeneration and renewal by the Holy Spirit. Psalm 36 showed you the steadfast love that extends to the heavens, and the fountain of life. Psalm 139 reminded you that you are fully known and fearfully and wonderfully made. In John 4 you watched Jesus offer living water to a Samaritan woman, and saw a whole town believe. The doctrinal pause on worship taught you that the Father seeks those who worship in spirit and truth, through Christ. In John 5 you saw Jesus heal a man who could not help himself, and heard him claim equality with the Father and promise that whoever believes has passed from death to life.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Regeneration is God’s work, not ours. How does that change the way you think about your own faith, and about praying for those who do not believe?

Jesus offered the Samaritan woman living water, the gift of the Spirit. Where do you most need that water right now?

Jesus said the Scriptures bear witness about him. How does keeping that in mind change the way you read the Bible?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for giving you new birth.

Thank him for seeking you as a worshiper.

Ask him to teach you to worship in spirit and truth.

DAY 645 · WEEK 93

John 6:1-71

The bread of life, sovereign grace and discipleship

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 6:1-71. Jesus feeds the five thousand, walks on the sea, and then teaches in the synagogue at Capernaum that he is the bread of life. Many disciples leave. Notice the tension between God's drawing and the human response.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is near Passover, and a great crowd has followed Jesus because of his signs. The feeding of the five thousand is the only miracle, apart from the resurrection, that appears in all four Gospels. John uses it as a sign pointing to Jesus himself. The long discourse that follows is one of the most challenging in the Gospel, and it ends with a crisis of belief.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Jesus then took the loaves, and when he had given thanks, he distributed them to those who were seated" (6:11).
2. "It is I; do not be afraid" (6:20).
3. "This is the work of God, that you believe in him whom he has sent" (6:29).
4. "I am the bread of life; whoever comes to me shall not hunger, and whoever believes in me shall never thirst" (6:35).
5. "All that the Father gives me will come to me, and whoever comes to me I will never cast out" (6:37).
6. "No one can come to me unless the Father who sent me draws him. And I will raise him up on the last day" (6:44).

7. “Unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink his blood, you have no life in you” (6:53).

8. “Lord, to whom shall we go? You have the words of eternal life” (6:68).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus tests Philip with a question about where to buy bread for the crowd. Andrew finds a boy with five barley loaves and two fish. Jesus gives thanks, distributes the food, and everyone eats their fill, with twelve baskets left over. The crowd wants to make him king by force, and he withdraws. That night he walks on the sea to the disciples in the storm, saying, “It is I; do not be afraid.” The Greek is “I am,” the divine name.

The crowd finds him the next day, looking for more bread. He says, “You are seeking me, not because you saw signs, but because you ate your fill.” They ask what work they must do, and he says that the work of God is to believe in the one he sent. They ask for a sign like the manna that Moses gave. Jesus says the true bread from heaven is a person: “I am the bread of life.” The one who comes to him will never hunger, and the one who believes will never thirst.

Then he speaks of the Father’s work. “All that the Father gives me will come to me, and whoever comes to me I will never cast out.” Here is the double truth of salvation. The Father gives, and the Son receives. Everyone given will come, and no one who comes will be turned away. “No one can come to me unless the Father who sent me draws him.” Salvation begins with God. And yet the invitation is real: “whoever comes.” Reformed Christians have found in this chapter a clear statement of God’s sovereign grace, and all Christians find in it a promise that Jesus will not reject anyone who comes.

The talk of eating his flesh and drinking his blood scandalizes the crowd. Jesus is speaking of feeding on him by faith, as the following verses make clear: “It is the Spirit who gives life; the flesh is no help.” Christians have also seen in these words a connection to the Lord’s Supper. Many disciples turn back and no longer walk with him. Jesus asks the Twelve, “Do you want to go away also?” Peter answers for them: “Lord, to whom shall we go? You have the words of eternal life, and we have believed, and have come to know, that you are the Holy One of God.” Peter does not understand everything, but he knows there is no one else.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 16 is the manna in the wilderness. Psalm 78:24-25 speaks of the bread of heaven. Isaiah 55:1-3 invites the hungry to come and eat. Deuteronomy 8:3 says man does not live by bread alone. Matthew 14:13-33 is the parallel to the feeding and the walk on water. 1

Corinthians 10:16-17 and 11:23-26 speak of the bread of the Lord's Supper. Ephesians 1:4-5 and Romans 8:29-30 speak of God's choosing.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you are hungry for. Are you coming to Jesus for his gifts or for himself?

Rest in verse 37: if you have come to Jesus, he will never cast you out.

When doctrine is hard, say Peter's words: "Lord, to whom shall we go?"

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus what you hunger for, and thank him that he is the bread of life.
- Thank him that whoever comes to him he will never cast out.
- Ask him to keep you from turning away.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 93

"I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."

JOHN 8:12

DAY 646 · WEEK 93

John 7:1-8:11

At the Feast of Booths; the woman caught in adultery

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 7:1-8:11. Jesus teaches at the Feast of Booths amid confusion about who he is, and then a woman caught in adultery is brought to him. A note: the story in 7:53-8:11 is not found in the earliest manuscripts, and many translations set it apart. It is widely accepted as an authentic account of Jesus, though scholars differ on whether John wrote it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Feast of Booths was a joyful autumn festival that remembered the wilderness wanderings. Each day a priest drew water from the pool of Siloam and poured it at the altar, and lamps lit up the temple courts. Against this background, Jesus stands on the last and greatest day and offers living water. The crowd is divided. The leaders are looking for a way to arrest him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “If anyone’s will is to do God’s will, he will know whether the teaching is from God or whether I am speaking on my own authority” (7:17).
2. “So they were seeking to arrest him, but no one laid a hand on him, because his hour had not yet come” (7:30).
3. “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink” (7:37).
4. “Whoever believes in me, as the Scripture has said, Out of his heart will flow rivers of living water” (7:38).
5. “No one ever spoke like this man!” (7:46).

6. “Let him who is without sin among you be the first to throw a stone at her” (8:7).
7. “Woman, where are they? Has no one condemned you?” (8:10).
8. “Neither do I condemn you; go, and from now on sin no more” (8:11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus’ brothers urge him to go to Judea and show himself, but they do not believe in him. He says his time has not yet come, and goes up privately. At the feast, people debate. Some say he is a good man; others say he is leading the people astray. In the middle of the feast, he teaches in the temple. “My teaching is not mine, but his who sent me.” And he gives a principle for judging truth: if anyone is willing to do God’s will, he will know.

On the last day of the feast, when the water ceremony had ended, Jesus cries out, “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink.” John explains that he spoke about the Spirit, whom believers would receive after Jesus was glorified. The temple guards come back empty-handed, saying, “No one ever spoke like this man!” Nicodemus, who first came by night, speaks up for fairness.

Then the scene changes. The scribes and Pharisees bring a woman caught in adultery and set her before Jesus, quoting the law of Moses that she should be stoned. It is a trap: if he says to release her, he disregards the law, and if he says to stone her, he loses his reputation for mercy and contradicts Roman law. Jesus stoops and writes on the ground. When they keep asking, he says, “Let him who is without sin among you be the first to throw a stone at her.” One by one, beginning with the oldest, they go away. Jesus is left alone with the woman. “Has no one condemned you?” “No one, Lord.” “Neither do I condemn you; go, and from now on sin no more.”

Notice the order. Jesus does not say, “Go and sin no more, and then I will not condemn you.” He says he does not condemn, and then calls her to a new life. Grace comes first and makes obedience possible. And Jesus can say this because he is the one who will bear her condemnation on the cross.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 23:33-43 describes the Feast of Booths. Isaiah 12:3 and Zechariah 14:8, 16-19 connect living water and the feast to the age to come. Isaiah 44:3 promises the Spirit poured out on the thirsty. Deuteronomy 17:6-7 and Leviticus 20:10 relate to the case of adultery. Romans 8:1 says there is now no condemnation for those in Christ Jesus. Romans 3:23-24 says all have sinned and are justified by grace. Hebrews 4:15-16 speaks of our sympathetic high priest.

STEP 6

Application

If you are thirsty, go to Jesus and drink. Tell him what you are thirsting for.

Put down any stones you are holding against others. Remember your own sin.

Hear “Neither do I condemn you” as spoken to you, and then ask what “go and sin no more” looks like for you today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Come to Jesus thirsty, and tell him what you thirst for.
- Ask him to pour out his Spirit like rivers of living water.
- Thank him for his compassion for the woman caught in sin.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 93

“I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life.”

JOHN 8:12

DAY 647 · WEEK 93

John 8:12-59

“I AM the light of the world”; before Abraham was, I AM

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 48 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 8:12-59. Jesus declares himself the light of the world and argues with the leaders about freedom, fatherhood, and Abraham. It ends with the strongest claim to deity in the Gospel. Notice the “I AM” in verse 58.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The conflict at the Feast of Booths continues. The lamps in the temple courts would have been burning, and Jesus calls himself the light of the world. The discussion that follows grows heated, with the Jews claiming to be Abraham’s children and free, and Jesus pointing out that they are slaves to sin. It ends with Jesus saying the divine name over himself, and the crowd picking up stones.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life” (8:12).
2. “And you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free” (8:32).
3. “Truly, truly, I say to you, everyone who practices sin is a slave to sin” (8:34).
4. “So if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed” (8:36).
5. “You are of your father the devil, and your will is to do your father’s desires” (8:44).
6. “Your father Abraham rejoiced that he would see my day. He saw it and was glad” (8:56).
7. “Truly, truly, I say to you, before Abraham was, I am” (8:58).
8. “So they picked up stones to throw at him, but Jesus hid himself and went out of the temple” (8:59).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“I am the light of the world.” This is the second of John’s seven “I AM” statements (after the bread of life). The Old Testament pictures God as light, and as the one who led Israel with a pillar of fire. Whoever follows Jesus will not walk in darkness but will have the light of life. The Pharisees object that Jesus is bearing witness about himself, and he answers that his Father also bears witness.

Then he says, “You will die in your sins unless you believe that I am he.” This is the first of several uses of “I am” in the chapter. To the believers among them, he says, “If you abide in my word, you are truly my disciples, and you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free.” The Jews bristle: we are Abraham’s offspring and have never been enslaved. Jesus replies that everyone who sins is a slave to sin, and that only the Son can set them free. Freedom comes only from him.

The argument escalates. They claim Abraham as their father, and Jesus tells them Abraham would not have acted as they do. They claim God as their father, and Jesus says that if God were their Father, they would love him. Instead they are acting like the devil, who was a murderer from the beginning and a liar. These are harsh words, spoken to those who were trying to kill him.

Finally, they ask, “Are you greater than our father Abraham?” Jesus replies, “Your father Abraham rejoiced that he would see my day.” They are incredulous: “You are not yet fifty years old, and have you seen Abraham?” Then comes the verse: “Truly, truly, I say to you, before Abraham was, I am.” He does not say “I was.” He uses the divine name from Exodus 3:14. The leaders understand exactly what he is claiming, and they pick up stones. It is blasphemy unless it is true.

The chapter shows that the issue is not just Jesus’ teaching but his identity. If he is the eternal I AM, then he is the light, the truth, and the one who can set us free.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 3:14 is God’s name, I AM. Isaiah 41:4 and 43:10-13 also use “I am he.” Psalm 27:1 says the LORD is my light. Isaiah 9:2 and 60:1-3 promise light to those in darkness. John 1:4-9 says the Word is the light. Romans 6:16-18 explains slavery to sin and freedom in Christ. Galatians 5:1 says for freedom Christ has set us free. Hebrews 11:13 says the patriarchs saw the promises from afar. 1 John 1:5-7 says God is light.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you still walk in darkness. Bring that area to Jesus, the light.

What are you enslaved to? Bring it to the Son, who makes you free indeed.

Pray, “Jesus, you are the I AM,” and let the weight of that rest on you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus you want to follow the light of the world.
- Ask him to set you free from sin by his truth.
- Worship him as the great I AM.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 93

“I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life.”

JOHN 8:12

DAY 648 · WEEK 93

Psalm 119:97-120

Oh how I love your law; your word is a lamp

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 119:97-120. This section of the great psalm on God's word speaks of love for the law, sweetness, and light for the path. Read verse 105 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 119 is the longest chapter in the Bible, an acrostic of twenty-two stanzas, each beginning with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet. In this plan, it is spread across several days. Today's reading covers three stanzas, Mem, Nun, and Samekh, and speaks of the power of God's word. Jesus said that his word would make us free, and this psalm shows the heart that treasures it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh how I love your law! It is my meditation all the day" (v. 97).
2. "Your commandment makes me wiser than my enemies, for it is ever with me" (v. 98).
3. "How sweet are your words to my taste, sweeter than honey to my mouth!" (v. 103).
4. "Through your precepts I get understanding; therefore I hate every false way" (v. 104).
5. "Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path" (v. 105).
6. "You are my hiding place and my shield; I hope in your word" (v. 114).
7. "Hold me up, that I may be safe and have regard for your statutes continually!" (v. 117).
8. "My flesh trembles for fear of you, and I am afraid of your judgments" (v. 120).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The stanza called Mem begins with an exclamation of love: “Oh how I love your law!” The psalmist is not describing a duty but a delight. He meditates on God’s word all day, and it makes him wiser than his enemies, wiser than his teachers, and wiser than the aged. It gives him wisdom because it comes from God and it shapes his conduct. He keeps his feet from every evil way. Then comes the sweetness: “How sweet are your words to my taste, sweeter than honey to my mouth!”

The next stanza, Nun, begins with the best-known line: “Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path.” A lamp in the ancient world did not light up the whole road. It showed the next step. God’s word may not tell us everything about the future, but it shows us enough to take the next step. The psalmist has sworn to keep God’s righteous rules, and he is deeply afflicted, yet he says, “Give me life, O LORD, according to your word.” The word is both light and life. He asks that the LORD accept his freewill offerings of praise, and says that God’s testimonies are the joy of his heart.

In Samekh, the psalmist hates the double-minded and loves God’s law. “You are my hiding place and my shield; I hope in your word.” Here the word is not just a lamp but a shelter. He asks for help to keep the commandments and for God to uphold him: “Hold me up, that I may be safe.” He knows that on his own he cannot stand. The stanza ends with fear and trembling: “My flesh trembles for fear of you.” A right fear of God does not exclude love; it deepens it.

In John, Jesus is the Word, and he said, “If you abide in my word, you are truly my disciples.” To love God’s word is to love him. Jesus Christ fulfilled the law the psalmist loved, and the Spirit he sends writes it on our hearts.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 1:2 and 19:7-11 also praise the delight of the law. Joshua 1:8 commands meditation on the book of the law. Jeremiah 15:16 says your words became to me a joy. Matthew 4:4 quotes Deuteronomy 8:3, that man lives by every word from God’s mouth. John 8:31-32 and 17:17 speak of the truth of the word. 2 Timothy 3:16-17 says all Scripture is breathed out by God. Hebrews 4:12 says the word of God is living and active.

STEP 6

Application

Read verse 105 aloud and ask what the next step is for you. Where do you need light?

Choose a short passage and meditate on it throughout the day, as verse 97 describes.

Ask God to make his word sweeter to you than honey. Pray it honestly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you love about his law.
- Ask him to let it be your meditation all the day.
- Ask him to light your path with it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 93

"I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."

JOHN 8:12

DAY 649 · WEEK 93

Psalm 43

Send out your light and your truth

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 43. It is a short prayer from someone in darkness, asking for God's light and truth to lead him to worship. It pairs with Psalm 42, and it ends with a refrain of hope.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 43 has no title and was likely the last stanza of Psalm 42, since they share the same refrain: "Why are you cast down, O my soul?" The singer is far from the temple, mocked by enemies and deeply discouraged. His prayer is for God to send light and truth to bring him back to worship. It follows Psalm 119 and John 8 in the theme of light and truth.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Vindicate me, O God" (v. 1).
2. "You are the God in whom I take refuge" (v. 2).
3. "Why do I go mourning because of the oppression of the enemy?" (v. 2).
4. "Send out your light and your truth; let them lead me" (v. 3).
5. "Let them bring me to your holy hill and to your dwelling!" (v. 3).
6. "To God my exceeding joy" (v. 4).
7. "Why are you cast down, O my soul, and why are you in turmoil within me?" (v. 5).
8. "Hope in God; for I shall again praise him, my salvation and my God" (v. 5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a legal appeal. The singer asks God to vindicate him and defend his cause against a people who are deceitful and unjust. Then he turns to a question that many believers have asked: “For you are the God in whom I take refuge; why have you rejected me?” He is confused. God is his refuge, and yet he feels abandoned. “Why do I go mourning because of the oppression of the enemy?” The psalm lets us ask hard questions.

The center of the prayer is verse 3: “Send out your light and your truth; let them lead me.” He does not ask for an explanation of why he is suffering. He asks for light and truth, as if they were two guides sent from God. Light shows the path. Truth keeps him from deception. Together they will lead him to the holy hill and to God’s dwelling, where he can worship. John 1 and 14 tell us who God sent: Jesus is the light of the world, and he is the truth. He leads us to the Father.

The goal is worship: “Then I will go to the altar of God, to God my exceeding joy.” What he longs for is not just relief from his enemies but God himself. God is his exceeding joy. Then he will praise God with the lyre.

The psalm ends with a conversation with himself. “Why are you cast down, O my soul, and why are you in turmoil within me?” He does not deny his feelings. He questions them. And he answers: “Hope in God; for I shall again praise him, my salvation and my God.” Notice the word “again.” He is not praising now, but he knows he will. Depression and discouragement are real, and God’s people are not exempt, but they are not the last word. Our hope is in the God who will bring light.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 42 shares the refrain. Psalm 27:1 and 36:9 speak of the LORD as light. Psalm 119:105 calls the word a lamp. John 1:9, 8:12, and 14:6 apply light and truth to Jesus. Lamentations 3:21-26 teaches hope in the LORD in the midst of grief. Romans 15:13 prays that the God of hope would fill you with joy and peace. 2 Corinthians 4:8-9 says we are afflicted but not crushed.

STEP 6

Application

When you are cast down, speak to your soul as the psalmist did. Say, “Hope in God.”

Pray verse 3 as a prayer for guidance: “Send out your light and your truth.”

Tell a trusted friend honestly if you are struggling. You do not need to carry it alone.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God where you feel forgotten.
- Ask him to send out his light and truth.
- Tell your soul to hope in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 93

"I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."

JOHN 8:12

DAY 650 · WEEK 93

John 9:1-10:21

The man born blind; the Good Shepherd

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 9:1-10:21. Jesus heals a man born blind, the Pharisees interrogate him, and Jesus then speaks of himself as the door and the good shepherd. Follow the blind man's growth from not knowing, to knowing, to worship.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Still in Jerusalem, Jesus passes a man who has been blind from birth. The disciples ask whose sin caused it, a common assumption. Jesus gives another answer. What follows is a masterpiece of storytelling: the healing, a series of interrogations, and the man's confession. It leads into Jesus' words about the sheep and the shepherd, which echo Ezekiel 34, where God promises to shepherd his scattered flock.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It was not that this man sinned, or his parents, but that the works of God might be displayed in him" (9:3).
2. "One thing I do know, that though I was blind, now I see" (9:25).
3. "For judgment I came into this world, that those who do not see may see, and those who see may become blind" (9:39).
4. "I am the door. If anyone enters by me, he will be saved and will go in and out and find pasture" (10:9).
5. "I came that they may have life and have it abundantly" (10:10).
6. "I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep" (10:11).
7. "So there will be one flock, one shepherd" (10:16).

8 “No one takes it from me, but I lay it down of my own accord” (10:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus rejects the idea that this man’s blindness was the direct result of someone’s sin. It was so that the works of God might be displayed in him. He spits on the ground, makes mud, anoints the man’s eyes, and tells him to wash in the pool of Siloam. The man goes, washes, and returns seeing.

The neighbors can hardly believe it, and the Pharisees investigate. It was the Sabbath again. The man’s answers grow bolder at each stage. First: “The man called Jesus made mud.” Then: “He is a prophet.” When the leaders press him, he says, “One thing I do know, that though I was blind, now I see.” He cannot explain everything, but he knows what happened. They mock him, and he says, with a touch of irony, “Do you also want to become his disciples?” They throw him out. Jesus finds him and asks, “Do you believe in the Son of Man?” “Lord, I believe,” he says, and worships. The blind man sees, and those who claim to see remain blind.

Jesus then turns to the image of the sheep. The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy. Jesus has come that his sheep may have life and have it abundantly. He is the door: whoever enters through him will be saved. He is also the good shepherd, who knows his sheep by name, and whom the sheep know. The hired hand flees when the wolf comes, but the shepherd lays down his life for the sheep.

Notice the contrast. The false shepherds, the religious leaders who cast out the blind man, care for themselves. Jesus, the true shepherd, seeks the outcast. He says he has other sheep who are not of this fold, a reference to the Gentiles, and “there will be one flock, one shepherd.” And his death is no accident: “No one takes it from me, but I lay it down of my own accord. I have authority to lay it down, and authority to take it up again.”

The Father’s command and the Son’s authority are in harmony. The shepherd dies willingly, and rises. The people divide again over his words. This is the third and fourth of the “I AM” sayings, the door and the good shepherd.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 23 and Ezekiel 34 are the great shepherd passages. Isaiah 35:5 and 42:7 promise sight for the blind. Isaiah 42:16 says God will lead the blind in a way they do not know. Jeremiah 23:1-4 condemns false shepherds. Zechariah 11 pictures the rejected shepherd. 1 Peter 2:25 says we have returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of our souls. Hebrews 13:20 calls Jesus the great shepherd of the sheep. Revelation 7:17 says the Lamb will be their shepherd.

STEP 6

Application

Tell someone your own “I was blind, but now I see” in a sentence or two.

Listen for the shepherd’s voice in his word today. What is he saying to you?

Pray for someone who has been cast out or hurt by the church. Ask Jesus to find them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus, “I was blind, and now I see,” and name something he has shown you.
- Ask him to help you hear the Shepherd’s voice.
- Worship him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 93

“I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life.”

JOHN 8:12

DAY 651 · WEEK 93

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read John 8:12 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."

JOHN 8:12

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this in the temple courts during the Feast of Booths, when the great lamps were lit. It is one of the seven great "I AM" statements of John's Gospel.

"I am the light of the world." The claim is huge. Not a light, but the light. Not of Israel only, but of the world. In the Bible, light is the first thing God created, and it is a picture of his holiness, truth, and life. Jesus says he is that light in person.

"Whoever follows me." Light is for walking by. It is not enough to admire it. Following means putting one foot in front of the other behind him, trusting him with the path.

"Will not walk in darkness." Darkness means sin, ignorance, and death. The one who follows Jesus is not left to stumble. Even when the path is hard, he is not lost.

"But will have the light of life." He will not only see by the light, he will have it, as his own possession. The light is life itself. Jesus does not just show the way; he gives life.

When you feel confused or lost, say this verse. He is the light, and you do not have to find the way alone.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week Jesus fed five thousand and declared himself the bread of life, and you heard Peter say, “To whom shall we go? You have the words of eternal life.” At the Feast of Booths he offered living water and said, “Neither do I condemn you” to a woman caught in sin. He declared himself the light of the world, promised that the Son sets us free indeed, and used the divine name of himself: “Before Abraham was, I am.” In the Psalms you read about delighting in God’s word as a lamp for your feet (Psalm 119), and you prayed for light and truth to lead you out of discouragement (Psalm 43). In John 9 and 10 you watched a blind man receive sight and worship, and heard Jesus say that he is the door and the good shepherd who lays down his life for the sheep.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said, “I am the bread of life.” What do you tend to hunger for in place of him, and what would it mean to feed on him this week?

The woman caught in adultery heard, “Neither do I condemn you; go, and from now on sin no more.” How does the order, grace first and then a call to change, shape how you deal with your own sin?

Jesus is the good shepherd who lays down his life for the sheep. What does it mean for you personally that he knows you by name?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for being the light, the bread, the door, and the good shepherd.

Tell him which of these you most need today.

Rest in him.

DAY 652 · WEEK 94

John 10:22-11:57

I and the Father are one; Lazarus raised

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 87 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 10:22-11:57. Jesus declares that he and the Father are one, and then raises Lazarus from the dead. Notice how the raising of Lazarus both displays his glory and sets his death in motion.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is winter, at the Feast of Dedication (Hanukkah), which celebrated the cleansing of the temple. The Jews press Jesus to say plainly whether he is the Christ. His answer leads to a second attempt to stone him. He withdraws across the Jordan, and then receives word that his friend Lazarus, in Bethany near Jerusalem, is sick. The seventh and greatest sign in John's Gospel follows.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "My sheep hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me" (10:27).
2. "I give them eternal life, and they will never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand" (10:28).
3. "I and the Father are one" (10:30).
4. "I am the resurrection and the life. Whoever believes in me, though he die, yet shall he live" (11:25).
5. "Jesus wept" (11:35).
6. "Lazarus, come out" (11:43).
7. "Unbind him, and let him go" (11:44).

8 “It is better for you that one man should die for the people, not that the whole nation should perish” (11:50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“If you are the Christ, tell us plainly,” they say. Jesus replies that he has told them, and his works testify, but they do not believe because they are not among his sheep. Then he gives some of the most comforting words in the Bible. His sheep hear his voice. He knows them, and they follow him. He gives them eternal life. They will never perish, and no one can snatch them out of his hand. Then he says the Father’s hand holds them too: “No one is able to snatch them out of the Father’s hand.” This is the security of every believer. Salvation is held by God, not by the strength of our grip. And then: “I and the Father are one.” The Jews pick up stones, for they understand he is claiming to be God.

When word comes that Lazarus is ill, Jesus waits two more days. This looks like neglect, but he explains that the illness is for the glory of God. When he arrives, Lazarus has been dead four days. Martha meets him and says, “Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died.” Jesus says, “Your brother will rise again.” She believes in the resurrection at the last day. Then Jesus says, “I am the resurrection and the life. Whoever believes in me, though he die, yet shall he live, and everyone who lives and believes in me shall never die.” He asks, “Do you believe this?” Martha answers with one of the great confessions: “Yes, Lord; I believe that you are the Christ, the Son of God.”

When Mary comes weeping, Jesus is deeply moved in spirit and troubled. Then comes the shortest verse in the English Bible: “Jesus wept.” The Son of God, who knows he is about to raise Lazarus, weeps with those who weep. He is not distant from our grief. At the tomb he prays aloud for the sake of the crowd and cries, “Lazarus, come out!” The dead man comes out, bound in grave clothes. “Unbind him, and let him go.”

The sign brings belief to many, but the chief priests and Pharisees decide that Jesus must die. Caiaphas, the high priest, says unwittingly that it is better for one man to die for the people. John comments that he prophesied that Jesus would die for the nation, and to gather into one the children of God who are scattered abroad. The miracle that gave life to Lazarus will lead to the death of Jesus. The giver of life gives his own.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 23 and Ezekiel 34 are the background to the sheep imagery. Isaiah 25:8 promises that God will swallow up death forever. Daniel 12:2 speaks of those who sleep in the dust awakening. Hosea 13:14 says God will ransom them from the power of Sheol. 1 Corinthians

15:20-26 speaks of Christ's resurrection as the firstfruits. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 comforts those grieving believers. Romans 8:35-39 speaks of the security of those loved by Christ. Hebrews 4:15 says we have a high priest who sympathizes with our weaknesses.

STEP 6

Application

Rest in verses 28 and 29. Your salvation is held in the hands of Christ and the Father.

Bring your grief to Jesus, who wept. Tell him what you have lost.

Ask Martha's question of yourself: "Do you believe this?" Answer it in your own words.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that no one can snatch you from his hand.
- Ask him to help you hear his voice.
- Thank him that he and the Father are one.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 94

"I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

JOHN 14:6

DAY 653 · WEEK 94

John 12:1-50

The anointing; the Entry; the grain of wheat must die

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 12:1-50. Mary anoints Jesus, the crowds welcome him into Jerusalem, Greeks seek him, and he speaks of the grain of wheat that must die. The first half of John's Gospel ends here. Read verses 23 to 33 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Six days before Passover, Jesus returns to Bethany for a supper in his honor. Lazarus is at the table. Large crowds come to see both Jesus and Lazarus, and many are believing. Meanwhile the chief priests plot to kill Lazarus as well. Jesus enters Jerusalem to the shouts of the crowd. Then the "hour" that has been mentioned throughout the Gospel finally arrives.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Mary therefore took a pound of expensive ointment made from pure nard, and anointed the feet of Jesus and wiped his feet with her hair. The house was filled with the fragrance of the perfume" (12:3).
2. "Hosanna! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord, even the King of Israel!" (12:13).
3. "Unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies, it bears much fruit" (12:24).
4. "Whoever loves his life loses it, and whoever hates his life in this world will keep it for eternal life" (12:25).
5. "And I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to myself" (12:32).

6. “They loved the glory that comes from man more than the glory that comes from God” (12:43).
7. “I have come into the world as light, so that whoever believes in me may not remain in darkness” (12:46).
8. “For I did not come to judge the world but to save the world” (12:47).

STEP 4

Interpretation

At the supper, Mary takes a pound of costly perfume, pours it on Jesus’ feet, and wipes them with her hair. The house fills with the fragrance. Judas objects, saying it should have been sold and given to the poor, though John says he was a thief. Jesus defends her: “Leave her alone, so that she may keep it for the day of my burial.” She gives extravagantly, and Jesus accepts it as worship.

The next day, a large crowd takes palm branches and goes out to meet him, shouting “Hosanna! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord, even the King of Israel!” Jesus sits on a young donkey, as Zechariah foretold. The Pharisees say, “Look, the world has gone after him.”

Some Greeks, Gentiles who had come to worship at the feast, ask to see Jesus. When Philip and Andrew tell him, Jesus says, “The hour has come for the Son of Man to be glorified.” The hour he has been waiting for is here, and it is tied to the coming of the nations. Then he says, “Unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies, it bears much fruit.” His death will not end his work but multiply it. And the principle applies to his followers: “Whoever loves his life loses it.”

Jesus is troubled: “Now is my soul troubled. And what shall I say? Father, save me from this hour? But for this purpose I have come to this hour. Father, glorify your name.” A voice from heaven answers. Then he says, “And I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to myself.” John explains that he said this to show by what kind of death he was going to die. The cross is the throne, and from it he draws people of every nation.

John closes the first half of the Gospel with a sad note. Despite so many signs, they did not believe, and John quotes Isaiah on hardness of heart. Some leaders believed but would not confess, “for they loved the glory that comes from man more than the glory that comes from God.” Jesus cries out once more: he has come as light, to save and not to judge.

STEP 5

Connection

Zechariah 9:9 is the donkey. Psalm 118:25-26 is the hosanna. Isaiah 53:1 and 6:10 are quoted at the end. Numbers 21:8-9 is the lifted bronze serpent. Genesis 12:3 promised the blessing to all nations. Galatians 2:20 says we have been crucified with Christ. Philippians 3:7-8 counts everything as loss for the sake of Christ. Mark 14:3-9 and Matthew 26:6-13 tell the story of the anointing.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what extravagant act of love you might offer Jesus, in time or money or service.

Consider what it means for you to "die" like the grain of wheat: what are you holding that needs to fall into the earth?

Pray for the nations: that the Greeks of our day would see Jesus.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you pour out your best on Jesus, as Mary did.

Ask him to teach you what it means to die like the grain of wheat.

Tell him what you want to lay down.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 94

"I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

JOHN 14:6

DAY 654 · WEEK 94

John 13:1-14:31

The foot washing; "I AM the way"; the Spirit promised

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 13:1-14:31. The Upper Room begins: Jesus washes his disciples' feet, gives a new commandment, predicts betrayal and denial, and then comforts them with promises of the Father's house, the Way, and the Holy Spirit. Take your time. These are among the most tender chapters in the Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is the night before Jesus' death. He is in an upper room in Jerusalem with the Twelve. John spends five chapters (13 to 17) on this one evening, and he omits the Lord's Supper itself. The tone shifts: no more public debates, only a Teacher preparing his friends for his departure. Judas leaves early, and in the darkness Jesus says words of great love.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Having loved his own who were in the world, he loved them to the end" (13:1).
2. "If I then, your Lord and Teacher, have washed your feet, you also ought to wash one another's feet" (13:14).
3. "A new commandment I give to you, that you love one another: just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another" (13:34).
4. "By this all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another" (13:35).
5. "Let not your hearts be troubled. Believe in God; believe also in me" (14:1).
6. "I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me" (14:6).

7. “And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Helper, to be with you forever” (14:16).

8. “Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you. Not as the world gives do I give to you” (14:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“Having loved his own… he loved them to the end.” Jesus rises from supper, takes off his outer garments, and wraps a towel around his waist. He pours water into a basin and begins to wash the disciples’ feet, a task for the lowest servant. Peter objects: “You shall never wash my feet.” Jesus replies, “If I do not wash you, you have no share with me.” The washing points to the cleansing that Jesus will accomplish on the cross. Then he explains the example: “If I then, your Lord and Teacher, have washed your feet, you also ought to wash one another’s feet.” The King serves.

He predicts that one of them will betray him. Judas leaves, and John says, “And it was night.” Jesus then says, “Now is the Son of Man glorified.” He gives the new commandment: love one another as I have loved you. Love is the badge of discipleship. Peter declares that he will lay down his life for Jesus, and Jesus answers that he will deny him three times.

Chapter 14 opens with comfort. “Let not your hearts be troubled.” He is going to prepare a place in his Father’s house, which has many rooms, and he will come again and take them to himself. Thomas objects, “We do not know where you are going. How can we know the way?” Jesus replies with the sixth “I AM”: “I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me.” This is the exclusive claim of the gospel and also a great invitation. The way is a person, and he is available to anyone who comes.

Philip asks, “Show us the Father.” Jesus says, “Whoever has seen me has seen the Father.” Then comes the promise of the Spirit. Jesus will ask the Father, and he will give another Helper, the Spirit of truth, who dwells with them and will be in them. “I will not leave you as orphans; I will come to you.” The Spirit will teach them and remind them of all that Jesus said. Finally: “Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you.” He leaves them not with an escape from trouble but with his peace.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 12 is the Passover context of the meal. Isaiah 52:13 and 53:11-12 describe the suffering servant. Psalm 41:9 predicts the betrayal. Leviticus 19:18 is the old love commandment. Isaiah 43:1-2 promises the presence of God in trouble. Ezekiel 36:27

promised the Spirit within. Acts 2 records the coming of the Spirit. Philippians 2:5-8 shows the same servant attitude. 1 John 3:16 and 4:7-12 build on the new commandment.

STEP 6

Application

Find a way to serve someone this week in a hidden, humble way, like washing feet.

Say verse 1 to yourself when you are anxious, and name what troubles your heart.

Thank the Father for Jesus, the way, the truth, and the life. Pray for someone who does not yet know him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for loving you to the end and washing feet.
- Ask him to teach you to serve.
- Ask him to help you love others as he has loved you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 94

"I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

JOHN 14:6

DAY 655 · WEEK 94

Psalm 23

The LORD is my shepherd

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 23. This is the best known of all the psalms. Read it slowly, as though for the first time, and hear Jesus say, “I am the good shepherd.”

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 23 is a psalm of David, who had been a shepherd. He knew what it was to guard sheep from lions and bears, to lead them to water, to count them at night. Here he uses that experience to describe the LORD’s care for him. The psalm moves from the pasture to the valley to the banquet table to the house of the LORD. It follows the good shepherd of John 10.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want” (v. 1).
2. “He makes me lie down in green pastures” (v. 2).
3. “He leads me beside still waters” (v. 2).
4. “He restores my soul” (v. 3).
5. “He leads me in paths of righteousness for his name’s sake” (v. 3).
6. “Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me; your rod and your staff, they comfort me” (v. 4).
7. “You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies; you anoint my head with oil; my cup overflows” (v. 5).
8. “Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life, and I shall dwell in the house of the LORD forever” (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“The LORD is my shepherd.” This is the foundation. The covenant name of God, Yahweh, is joined with a word of personal care. He is not just the shepherd of Israel in general; he is mine. “I shall not want” means that under his care nothing essential will be lacking.

The first scene is the pasture. A sheep will not lie down unless it is free from fear, from hunger, from friction in the flock, and from pests. The shepherd must provide all of this. “He makes me lie down in green pastures. He leads me beside still waters.” He restores my soul, meaning he brings me back when I wander, and renews me. He leads me in paths of righteousness, not because I deserve it but “for his name’s sake.” His reputation is bound up with his flock.

The scene shifts to the valley. “Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death.” The path to the good pasture often goes through dark ravines. David does not say if, but “though.” And notice the change from “he” to “you” in the middle of the psalm. When the danger is greatest, David speaks directly to the shepherd: “for you are with me.” The rod fights off predators and the staff guides and rescues. They comfort him.

Then the picture changes to a banquet. The host prepares a table in the presence of enemies. They cannot touch him. He anoints his guest’s head with oil, and the cup overflows. The shepherd is also a host.

The psalm ends in hope: “Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life.” The word translated “follow” is a strong word, like pursuing. God’s goodness and steadfast love chase after us. And the destination is secure: “I shall dwell in the house of the LORD forever.”

Jesus said, “I am the good shepherd.” He is the one who leads, protects, and dies for the sheep. The 23rd Psalm is fulfilled in him.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 48:15 and 49:24 call God the shepherd of his people. Ezekiel 34:11-16 promises that God himself will seek and shepherd his sheep. Isaiah 40:11 pictures God gathering lambs in his arms. John 10:11-16, Hebrews 13:20, and 1 Peter 5:4 identify Jesus as the shepherd. Revelation 7:15-17 says the Lamb will be their shepherd and wipe away every tear. Psalm 16:11 and 27:4 speak of dwelling in his presence.

STEP 6

Application

Read the psalm aloud, putting your own name in: “The LORD is my shepherd, and I shall not want.”

Identify your valley right now. Say verse 4 to the Shepherd.

Memorize the psalm if you have not already. It will be with you in dark times.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you lack and what you want him to shepherd.
- Tell him about your valley, and that you are with him there.
- Thank him for goodness and mercy following you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 94

“I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me.”

JOHN 14:6

DAY 656 · WEEK 94

Psalm 100

We are his people and the sheep of his pasture

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 100. It is a short psalm of thanksgiving, a call to the whole earth to come to the LORD with gladness. Read it aloud, as if you were entering the temple gates.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 100 is titled "A Psalm for giving thanks." It was probably sung by pilgrims as they entered the temple courts. It has a simple structure: two calls to worship (vv. 1 to 2 and 4), each followed by a reason (vv. 3 and 5). It has been sung for centuries by the church. It follows Psalm 23 with the same image of the flock.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Make a joyful noise to the LORD, all the earth!" (v. 1).
2. "Serve the LORD with gladness!" (v. 2).
3. "Come into his presence with singing!" (v. 2).
4. "Know that the LORD, he is God!" (v. 3).
5. "It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture" (v. 3).
6. "Enter his gates with thanksgiving, and his courts with praise!" (v. 4).
7. "Give thanks to him; bless his name!" (v. 4).
8. "For the LORD is good; his steadfast love endures forever, and his faithfulness to all generations" (v. 5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a command to all the earth, not just Israel: make a joyful noise. Worship is not meant to be grim. “Serve the LORD with gladness! Come into his presence with singing!” Service and joy go together. The word for serve is the word for work or worship, and it is to be done gladly.

Then comes the foundation: “Know that the LORD, he is God!” All true worship begins with knowing who God is. He is the LORD, the covenant God. “It is he who made us, and we are his.” We did not make ourselves, and we belong to him. “We are his people, and the sheep of his pasture.” The shepherd image returns. We are not self-made or self-sufficient. We are creatures and sheep, cared for by the Maker.

The second call is to enter his gates with thanksgiving and his courts with praise. Gratitude is the doorway to worship. We come not because we have earned entry, but because we have been invited. “Give thanks to him; bless his name!”

And the second reason is a threefold description of God: “For the LORD is good; his steadfast love endures forever, and his faithfulness to all generations.” Good describes his nature. Steadfast love describes his covenant commitment. Faithfulness describes his reliability across generations. This does not change. The generations before us trusted this God, and the generations after us will be able to.

The psalm is the response of the redeemed. In Christ, the invitation to the nations is extended to the world, and the flock is gathered from all peoples. The sheep of his pasture are those who hear his voice. John 10 says there will be one flock and one shepherd.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 95 is a similar call to worship. Psalm 117 invites all nations. Psalm 136 repeats “for his steadfast love endures forever.” Ezekiel 34:30-31 says the sheep are God’s people. Colossians 3:15-17 calls for thankfulness and singing. Hebrews 13:15 speaks of a sacrifice of praise. Revelation 7:9-12 pictures the nations praising God.

STEP 6

Application

Begin today with gladness. Give thanks for three things before you do anything else.

Sing a song of praise, or play one, and sing along.

Thank God for his faithfulness to your family, in the past and now.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Make a joyful noise to God, in your own words.

Thank him that you are his people and the sheep of his pasture.

Serve him with gladness today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 94

"I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

JOHN 14:6

DAY 657 · WEEK 94

Psalm 103

Bless the LORD, O my soul

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 103. It is one of the most beloved psalms of praise. David speaks to his own soul, and recounts the benefits of God: forgiveness, healing, redemption, and compassion. Read it slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 103 is a psalm of David. It opens with a self-address: "Bless the LORD, O my soul." Then it moves through a list of God's benefits, his character, his compassion for human weakness, and his everlasting throne. It ends with a call to the angels and all creation to bless him. Reading it after John 13 to 14 makes us see the love of the Father which Jesus came to show.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Bless the LORD, O my soul, and all that is within me, bless his holy name!" (v. 1).
2. "Who forgives all your iniquity, who heals all your diseases" (v. 3).
3. "The LORD is merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love" (v. 8).
4. "He does not deal with us according to our sins, nor repay us according to our iniquities" (v. 10).
5. "As far as the east is from the west, so far does he remove our transgressions from us" (v. 12).
6. "As a father shows compassion to his children, so the LORD shows compassion to those who fear him" (v. 13).
7. "For he knows our frame; he remembers that we are dust" (v. 14).

8 “But the steadfast love of the LORD is from everlasting to everlasting on those who fear him” (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David talks to himself. “Bless the LORD, O my soul, and all that is within me.” He gathers up his whole being, mind, heart, and will, to praise. And he reminds himself not to forget God’s benefits. We tend to forget. The list begins with the greatest: God forgives all our iniquity. He heals all our diseases. He redeems our life from the pit. He crowns us with steadfast love and mercy. He satisfies us with good, so that our youth is renewed like the eagle’s.

Verse 8 is a quotation of what God said to Moses on Sinai: “merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love.” It is the heart of the Old Testament’s picture of God. He does not always accuse or keep his anger forever. “He does not deal with us according to our sins.” If he did, none of us would survive. Instead, as high as the heavens are above the earth, so great is his steadfast love toward those who fear him. “As far as the east is from the west, so far does he remove our transgressions from us.” East and west never meet. Our sins are gone.

Then comes the tender image of a father: “As a father shows compassion to his children, so the LORD shows compassion to those who fear him.” Jesus came to reveal the Father in this way. “For he knows our frame; he remembers that we are dust.” God is not surprised by our weakness. He knows what we are made of. Human life is brief, like grass, but the steadfast love of the LORD is from everlasting to everlasting.

The psalm ends with a widening circle of praise. God’s throne is established in the heavens, and his kingdom rules over all. Angels, mighty ones, hosts, and all his works in all places are called to bless the LORD. And the psalm ends where it began: “Bless the LORD, O my soul!”

How can God forgive sin so completely and still be just? The cross answers that question. The Father removed our transgressions as far as the east is from the west because the Son bore them.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 34:6-7 is the source of verse 8. Isaiah 40:6-8 contrasts the grass with the word of God. Micah 7:18-19 says God casts all our sins into the depths of the sea. Isaiah 38:17 says he has cast all my sins behind his back. Luke 15:20 is the father running to the prodigal. Romans 3:25-26 explains how God is just and the justifier. Ephesians 1:7 says in him we have redemption through his blood. Hebrews 8:12 promises that he will remember our sins no more.

STEP 6

Application

Write a list of God's benefits to you, as David did. Read it aloud and give thanks.

Take a sin you cannot forgive in yourself and place it as far as the east is from the west.

Speak to your own soul: "Bless the LORD, O my soul."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bless the LORD with all that is within you.

Name a benefit of his that you do not want to forget.

Thank him that he removes your sin as far as the east is from the west.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 94

"I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

JOHN 14:6

DAY 658 · WEEK 94

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read John 14:6 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

JOHN 14:6

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this to Thomas in the upper room, on the last night before the cross. Thomas had asked, "How can we know the way?" and Jesus' answer is not a set of directions but himself.

"I am the way." Jesus is not just a guide who points. He is the road itself. We come to God not by our efforts, rituals, or goodness, but by Jesus. His death opens the path to God.

"And the truth." He is the reality behind all the shadows of the Old Testament, and the truth about God. Everything he says is true because he is truth.

"And the life." He gives life that death cannot end. He is the source of it, the one who raised Lazarus and who rose himself.

"No one comes to the Father except through me." This is exclusive and it is gracious. It is exclusive because there is only one way. It is gracious because the way is open to anyone who comes. No one is turned away.

When you wonder if you are on the right path, or when someone asks how a person can know God, say this verse. The way is a person, and he is here.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week Jesus declared that his sheep will never perish and that no one can snatch them from his hand. You stood at Lazarus's tomb and heard him say, "I am the resurrection and the life." You saw Mary pour out costly perfume and Jesus speak of the grain of wheat that must fall into the earth and die. In the Upper Room, he washed his disciples' feet, gave a new commandment, and comforted them with the promise of the Father's house, the Way, and the Helper. The Psalms were a chorus of the shepherd: Psalm 23, the LORD is my shepherd; Psalm 100, we are the sheep of his pasture; and Psalm 103, bless the LORD, O my soul, who forgives all your iniquity.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said no one can snatch his sheep out of his hand. How does this security affect how you think about doubt and failure?

At the Last Supper, Jesus washed feet and gave a new commandment to love one another. Who is one person you could serve or love this week in a way that costs you something?

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life. What does it mean to you that the way to the Father is a person and not a program?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that he is the way, truth, and life.

Thank him that his sheep are safe in his hand.

Rest in the Father's house.

DAY 659 · WEEK 95

John 15:1-16:33

"I AM the vine"; the Paraclete; sorrow turned to joy

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 15:1-16:33. Jesus continues his teaching in the Upper Room: the vine and the branches, the world's hatred, and the work of the Holy Spirit. It ends with sorrow turned to joy and a word of victory. Read 15:1-17 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The disciples have heard that Jesus is going away, and they are troubled. Jesus has told them to love one another and has promised the Spirit. Now, as they leave the upper room (14:31), he continues to teach, perhaps on the way to the garden. The image of the vine was familiar: Israel was often called God's vine in the Old Testament, and was often unfruitful. Jesus says that he is the true vine.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I am the true vine, and my Father is the vinedresser" (15:1).
2. "I am the vine; you are the branches. Whoever abides in me and I in him, he it is that bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing" (15:5).
3. "Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends" (15:13).
4. "You did not choose me, but I chose you and appointed you that you should go and bear fruit" (15:16).
5. "If the world hates you, know that it has hated me before it hated you" (15:18).
6. "It is to your advantage that I go away, for if I do not go away, the Helper will not come to you" (16:7).

7. “When the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth” (16:13).
8. “In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world” (16:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“I am the true vine, and my Father is the vinedresser.” This is the seventh and last of John’s “I AM” statements with a picture. Israel had been the vine that failed to bear good fruit (Isaiah 5), and Jesus is the true Israel who does. The Father is the gardener. He removes the branches that bear no fruit and prunes those that do, so that they bear more. Pruning is painful, but its purpose is fruitfulness.

The key word is “abide.” It means to remain, to stay connected. “Abide in me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit by itself, unless it abides in the vine, neither can you, unless you abide in me.” A branch has no life of its own. It lives by being joined to the vine. Apart from Jesus we can do nothing. Abiding in him means trusting him, keeping his words in us, praying, and loving as he loves. The fruit is Christlike character, and also lasting work and joy: “that my joy may be in you, and that your joy may be full.”

The vine teaches about union with Christ, which is at the center of the New Testament. We are not merely following his example; we are joined to him. His life flows into ours. The result is love: “As the Father has loved me, so have I loved you. Abide in my love.” The command is to love one another, and the model is his own sacrifice: “Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends.” He calls them friends, not servants, because he has made known to them all that he has heard from the Father. And in verse 16: “You did not choose me, but I chose you.” The initiative is his.

Then he warns that the world will hate them, as it hated him. Persecution will come. But the Spirit will come as Helper, testify about Jesus, convict the world of sin, righteousness, and judgment, and guide them into all the truth. The disciples are sad that Jesus is leaving, but he says it is to their advantage, because the Spirit will come. He uses the picture of a woman in labor: her pain turns to joy when the child is born. The disciples will weep, but their sorrow will become joy, and no one will take it from them.

The discourse ends with a promise: “In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world.” It is the victory he will win on the cross.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 5:1-7, Psalm 80:8-16, and Hosea 10:1 describe Israel as a vine. Jeremiah 2:21 says Israel became a degenerate wild vine. Ezekiel 15 and 19:10-14 speak of the vine's fruitlessness. Galatians 5:22-23 lists the fruit of the Spirit. Romans 6:5 and 11:17-24 speak of being united with Christ and grafted in. Colossians 1:27 speaks of Christ in you, the hope of glory. 1 John 2:6, 3:24, and 4:13 speak of abiding. Philippians 1:6 says God will complete his good work.

STEP 6

Application

Ask how you are abiding: in prayer, in the Word, in fellowship? Choose one practice to strengthen.

Think about a season of pruning in your life. Ask the vinedresser what fruit he is growing.

Say "I have overcome the world" to yourself the next time you are afraid.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you abide in the true vine.
- Confess where you try to produce fruit apart from him.
- Thank him for turning sorrow into joy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 95

"But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."

JOHN 20:31

DAY 660 · WEEK 95

John 17:1-26

The High Priestly Prayer, "that they may be one"

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 17:1-26. This is the longest prayer of Jesus in the Bible, often called the High Priestly Prayer. He prays for himself, for his disciples, and for all who will believe through their word. You are overhearing the Son pray for you. Read it slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus has finished teaching in the upper room. Before crossing the Kidron valley to the garden, he lifts his eyes to heaven and prays aloud, so that his disciples can hear. The prayer has three parts: for his own glorification (vv. 1 to 5), for the eleven disciples (vv. 6 to 19), and for all future believers (vv. 20 to 26). It is a rare glimpse into the intimate relationship between the Son and the Father, and into what Jesus wants for his people.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Father, the hour has come; glorify your Son that the Son may glorify you" (17:1).
2. "And this is eternal life, that they know you the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom you have sent" (17:3).
3. "I glorified you on earth, having accomplished the work that you gave me to do" (17:4).
4. "I do not ask that you take them out of the world, but that you keep them from the evil one" (17:15).
5. "Sanctify them in the truth; your word is truth" (17:17).
6. "That they may all be one, just as you, Father, are in me, and I in you, that they also may be in us" (17:21).

7. “Father, I desire that they also, whom you have given me, may be with me where I am, to see my glory” (17:24).

8. “That the love with which you have loved me may be in them, and I in them” (17:26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus begins by praying for himself, but his request is that the Son may glorify the Father. He has authority over all flesh so that he may give eternal life to all whom the Father has given him. Then he defines eternal life: “that they know you the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom you have sent.” Eternal life is not just endless time. It is a relationship, knowing God through Christ. He says he has finished the work he was given, and asks to be restored to the glory he had with the Father before the world existed. The Son who is about to die speaks as if it is finished, because it is certain.

Then he prays for the eleven. They are the Father’s gift to him, and he has given them the Father’s word. He prays, “I am not praying for the world but for those whom you have given me.” He asks that the Father keep them in his name, that they may be one. He does not ask that they be taken out of the world, but kept from the evil one. They are in the world but not of the world. And he asks, “Sanctify them in the truth; your word is truth.” To be sanctified is to be set apart and made holy, and it happens through the Word. Then, “As you sent me into the world, so I have sent them into the world.” The disciples are sent as he was sent.

The third part is for you, if you believe. “I do not ask for these only, but also for those who will believe in me through their word.” Jesus prayed for every future believer. He asks that they all may be one, “just as you, Father, are in me, and I in you.” The unity of believers reflects the unity of the Father and Son, and its purpose is mission: “so that the world may believe that you have sent me.” A divided church makes the gospel harder to believe. A united church is a witness.

He ends with the destination: “Father, I desire that they also, whom you have given me, may be with me where I am, to see my glory.” The goal of salvation is to be with Christ and to see him. And he says that the love of the Father for the Son will be in them. We are loved with the same love.

Notice how the prayer shows the security of the believer. The Son is praying for us, and the Father always hears him. As Romans 8:34 says, he is at the right hand of God, interceding for us.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 28 and Leviticus 16 describe the high priest's work. Hebrews 4:14-16 and 7:23-25 say Jesus is our great high priest who always lives to make intercession. Romans 8:34 says Christ intercedes for us. Isaiah 53:12 says he makes intercession for the transgressors. Ephesians 4:1-6 calls for the unity of the Spirit. Luke 22:32 records his prayer for Peter. 1 John 5:20 says to know the true God is eternal life. Revelation 21:3 promises that God will dwell with his people.

STEP 6

Application

Remember that Jesus has prayed for you by name. Write one sentence about what that means.

Pray this prayer back: for your own sanctification by the word, for your church's unity, and for the world to believe.

Reach out to a Christian from another tradition or community this week, as a sign of unity.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for praying for you before you were born.

Thank God that eternal life is knowing him.

Ask him to make you one with his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 95

"But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."

JOHN 20:31

DAY 661 · WEEK 95

John 18:1-19:16

Arrest; trials; Pilate

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 18:1-19:16. Jesus is arrested in a garden, questioned, denied by Peter, tried before Pilate, and sentenced to be crucified. Notice who is really in control, and the conversation about kingship and truth.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the prayer, Jesus crosses the Kidron valley to a garden, where Judas arrives with soldiers and officials. John tells the story of the trial from a different angle than the other Gospels. He leaves out Gethsemane's agony and the Jewish council's formal verdict, and emphasizes Jesus' sovereignty. The key scenes are the confrontation in the garden, the interview with Pilate, and the cry of the crowd.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Put your sword into its sheath; shall I not drink the cup that the Father has given me?" (18:11).
2. "Peter again denied it, and at once a rooster crowed" (18:27).
3. "My kingdom is not of this world" (18:36).
4. "Everyone who is of the truth listens to my voice" (18:37).
5. "What is truth?" (18:38).
6. "Behold the man!" (19:5).
7. "You would have no authority over me at all unless it had been given you from above" (19:11).
8. "We have no king but Caesar" (19:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

When the soldiers come, Jesus steps forward: “Whom do you seek?” “Jesus of Nazareth.” “I am he.” And they draw back and fall to the ground. Even in his arrest, his majesty shows. He asks them to let his disciples go, and they do. Peter strikes with a sword, and Jesus says, “Shall I not drink the cup that the Father has given me?” He is not a victim of events. He is going to the cross willingly.

Peter follows at a distance. In the courtyard, he is asked whether he is a disciple, and he denies it. Three times. Then a rooster crows. Meanwhile, inside, Jesus is questioned by Annas and then Caiaphas, and struck by an officer.

Before Pilate, the leaders do not enter the Gentile governor’s headquarters so they will not be defiled before Passover, a terrible irony as they seek the death of the innocent. Pilate asks, “Are you the King of the Jews?” Jesus answers, “My kingdom is not of this world.” It is a real kingdom, but it does not rely on swords. “For this purpose I was born… to bear witness to the truth. Everyone who is of the truth listens to my voice.” Pilate’s famous answer is a question, “What is truth?” He is standing in front of the Truth and does not know it. He tells the crowd three times that he finds no guilt in Jesus.

Pilate has Jesus flogged, and the soldiers put a crown of thorns on his head and a purple robe on him. Pilate brings him out: “Behold the man!” The King wears a crown of thorns, and he is exactly the man we need. When the leaders cry “Crucify him!”, Pilate says, “You take him and crucify him.” They say he has made himself the Son of God. Pilate becomes more afraid. “Do you not know that I have authority to release you and authority to crucify you?” Jesus answers, “You would have no authority over me at all unless it had been given you from above.” God is in control, and yet Pilate and the leaders are guilty.

Finally the chief priests say, “We have no king but Caesar.” The people who had longed for centuries for God to be their King now renounce him. Pilate hands Jesus over to be crucified. The innocent Lamb is handed over on the day of preparation for the Passover, at the very hour the Passover lambs were being slaughtered.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 3:14 is the “I am he” that made the soldiers fall back. Isaiah 53:7-8 describes the silent servant. Psalm 2:1-6 describes the nations raging against the LORD’s anointed. Daniel 7:14 gives the Son of Man a kingdom. Exodus 12 is the Passover lamb. 1 Timothy 6:13 says Christ Jesus made the good confession before Pilate. Romans 5:8 says Christ died for us while we were sinners. Acts 2:23 says he was delivered up according to the definite plan of God.

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on Peter's denial and Jesus' willingness to restore him. Bring any denial of your own to Jesus.

Ask what it would mean to let Christ be your King in an area you've kept for yourself.

Meditate on "Behold the man!" for a few minutes in silence.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for going willingly to the cross.

Confess where you have not listened to his kingdom's call.

Ask him to teach you to belong to his kingdom.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 95

"But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."

JOHN 20:31

DAY 662 · WEEK 95

John 19:17-42

The crucifixion, "It is finished"; the burial

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 19:17-42. Jesus is crucified, speaks his last words in John's Gospel, dies, and is buried. Read slowly. Notice how many Scriptures John says are fulfilled, and the cry "It is finished."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus carries his cross to Golgotha, the place of a skull. John, who was there, tells the story with simplicity and attention to detail. He alone records the conversation with his mother, the cry "I thirst," the word "It is finished," and the water and blood from his side. John presents the crucifixion not as defeat but as the hour of glory, the completion of the work the Father gave him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Jesus of Nazareth, the King of the Jews" (19:19).
2. "They divided my garments among them, and for my clothing they cast lots" (19:24).
3. "Woman, behold, your son!" (19:26).
4. "I thirst" (19:28).
5. "It is finished" (19:30).
6. "And he bowed his head and gave up his spirit" (19:30).
7. "But one of the soldiers pierced his side with a spear, and at once there came out blood and water" (19:34).
8. "Nicodemus, who earlier had come to Jesus by night, also came, bringing a mixture of myrrh and aloes, about seventy-five pounds in weight" (19:39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Pilate writes a sign for the cross: “Jesus of Nazareth, the King of the Jews,” in Hebrew, Latin, and Greek. The chief priests object, but Pilate says, “What I have written I have written.” Without knowing it, Pilate proclaims the truth to the world in three languages.

The soldiers divide his clothes into four parts and cast lots for the seamless tunic, fulfilling Psalm 22:18. John notes that nothing happens by accident. Near the cross stand his mother, her sister, Mary the wife of Clopas, and Mary Magdalene. Jesus sees his mother and the disciple whom he loved, and says, “Woman, behold, your son!” and “Behold, your mother!” Even in agony, he provides for his mother.

Then, “knowing that all was now finished,” he says, “I thirst.” Psalm 69:21 is fulfilled. They put a sponge of sour wine on a hyssop branch. Hyssop was used at the Passover to put the blood on the doorposts. Then he says, “It is finished,” and bows his head and gives up his spirit. The word is tetelestai, a word used for a paid debt. Jesus did not die as a helpless victim but as someone who completed the work of redemption: the debt paid, the sacrifice offered, the law fulfilled, the Father’s will done. He gave up his spirit; it was not taken from him.

To make sure the bodies do not remain on the crosses on the Sabbath, the soldiers break the legs of the other two men. But when they come to Jesus, they find that he is already dead, and instead a soldier pierces his side with a spear. Blood and water flow out. John emphasizes that he saw it and testifies to it. Not a bone is broken, fulfilling the Passover regulations about the lamb, and they will look on the one they have pierced (Zechariah 12:10). Jesus is the Passover Lamb.

Joseph of Arimathea, a secret disciple, and Nicodemus, who first came by night, step forward in the open. Nicodemus brings a hundred pounds of spices, a royal burial. They wrap the body and lay it in a new tomb in a garden, where no one had yet been laid. Two men who had been afraid now publicly honor Jesus. Death has done its worst. The scene is set for Sunday.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 22 describes the crucifixion with striking accuracy, and verses 16 to 18 are quoted here. Psalm 69:21 is the vinegar. Exodus 12:22 and 12:46 relate to hyssop and the unbroken bones. Zechariah 12:10 is the pierced one. Isaiah 53:9 says he was with a rich man in his death. Leviticus 16 and Hebrews 9:11-14 explain the sacrifice of atonement. Romans 3:23-26 and Colossians 2:13-14 say the debt of our sin was nailed to the cross. 1 John 5:6-8 speaks of water and blood.

STEP 6

Application

Spend time in silence with “It is finished.” What debt do you still try to pay on your own?

Look at Joseph and Nicodemus: are you hiding your faith? Ask for courage to be open.

Thank Jesus for caring for his mother even in agony. Whom can you care for today?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for saying, “It is finished,” and paying your debt in full.

Tell him what it means to rest in that.

Thank him for his care even in his dying.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 95

“But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name.”

JOHN 20:31

DAY 663 · WEEK 95

John 20:1-21:25

The resurrection; Thomas; the reinstatement of Peter

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 20:1-21:25. The empty tomb, the appearance to Mary Magdalene, to the disciples, and to Thomas, the purpose statement of the Gospel, and a breakfast on the beach where Jesus restores Peter. Read 20:30-31 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is early on the first day of the week, while it is still dark. Mary Magdalene comes to the tomb and finds the stone taken away. John's account is intimate and personal. He tells of his own race with Peter to the tomb, of Mary's tears, of Thomas's doubt, and of a morning by the Sea of Tiberias. The Gospel was originally written to end at chapter 20; chapter 21 is an epilogue that answers Peter's denial.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Jesus said to her, Mary. She turned and said to him in Aramaic, Rabboni!" (20:16).
2. "As the Father has sent me, even so I am sending you" (20:21).
3. "My Lord and my God!" (20:28).
4. "Blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed" (20:29).
5. "But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name" (20:31).
6. "Simon, son of John, do you love me more than these?" (21:15).
7. "Lord, you know everything; you know that I love you" (21:17).
8. "Follow me" (21:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Mary finds the tomb empty and runs to tell Peter and John. They run to the tomb. John arrives first but Peter goes in first, and they see the linen cloths lying there. John "saw and believed." Mary stays outside, weeping. Two angels ask why she is weeping, and then she turns and sees Jesus, but does not recognize him, thinking he is the gardener. He says one word: "Mary." She knows his voice. "Rabboni!" The good shepherd calls his sheep by name. He sends her to the disciples: "I am ascending to my Father and your Father, to my God and your God."

That evening, the disciples are behind locked doors. Jesus stands among them: "Peace be with you." He shows them his hands and side. "As the Father has sent me, even so I am sending you." He breathes on them and says, "Receive the Holy Spirit." He gives them authority to proclaim the forgiveness of sins.

Thomas was not there. He says he will not believe unless he sees the nail marks and puts his hand in his side. A week later, Jesus appears again. "Put your finger here, and see my hands." Thomas does not need to touch. He says the greatest confession in the Gospel: "My Lord and my God!" Jesus says, "Blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed." That includes every Christian since.

Then John states his purpose. Jesus did many other signs, but these are written "so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name." John selected his signs to produce faith. Everything in this Gospel is to bring us to belief, and life.

Chapter 21 shows Peter, who denied Jesus three times by a charcoal fire, restored by another charcoal fire. Seven disciples have gone fishing and caught nothing. A man on the shore tells them to cast on the right side, and the net is full. "It is the Lord!" Peter jumps in. On the beach Jesus has breakfast ready. Then he asks Peter three times, "Do you love me?" Peter is grieved, and says, "Lord, you know everything; you know that I love you." Each time Jesus gives him a charge: "Feed my lambs... Tend my sheep... Feed my sheep." The one who denied him is made a shepherd. Jesus also tells him how he will die and ends with "Follow me." The Gospel ends with John's note that the world could not contain the books if everything Jesus did were written.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 2 and 3 take place in a garden, as does the resurrection in John. Psalm 16:10 and Isaiah 53:10-12 speak of the Messiah's rising. Genesis 2:7 describes the breath of life, echoed in 20:22. Ezekiel 37:9-14 speaks of breath and the Spirit giving life. Luke 24:36-49 gives the

parallel appearance. 1 Corinthians 15:3-8 lists the witnesses to the resurrection. 1 Peter 1:8 says that though you have not seen him, you love him. 1 Peter 5:1-4 is Peter's later call to shepherd the flock.

STEP 6

Application

Hear Jesus call your name as he called Mary's. Respond with "Rabboni."

Confess with Thomas, "My Lord and my God," and mean it.

If you have failed Jesus, hear him ask, "Do you love me?" and answer honestly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Say to Jesus, "My Lord and my God," and mean it.
- Thank him for calling you by name.
- Hear him ask, "Do you love me?" and answer him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 95

"But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."

JOHN 20:31

DAY 664 · WEEK 95

Review and Reflection

Unit 17 review, The New Covenant Inaugurated, John

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life."
>
> JOHN 3:16

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this to Nicodemus in the night, and it has become the best known verse in the Bible. Every word carries weight.

"For God." The subject of the sentence is God. Salvation begins with him, not us.

"So loved." The word "so" means "in this way." This is how God loved: by giving. His love is not a feeling alone. It acts, at great cost.

"The world." Not just Israel, not just the good. The whole sinful, rebellious world. If God loved the world, he loves you.

"That he gave his only Son." The Father gave the Son he loved from all eternity. This is the gift of the cross, the greatest gift in history.

"That whoever believes in him." The way to receive the gift is belief, trust in Jesus. "Whoever" means anyone, with no exceptions.

"Should not perish but have eternal life." Two destinies: perishing or life. Eternal life begins now, in knowing God, and lasts forever.

When you doubt whether God cares about you, say this verse. It is the gospel in a sentence.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

You have read the whole Gospel of John, which was written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and by believing have life in his name. It began in eternity with the Word, who was with God and was God, and who became flesh and dwelt among us, full of grace and truth. Through seven signs and seven "I AM" statements, John showed who Jesus is: the bread of life, the light of the world, the door, the good shepherd, the resurrection and the life, the way, the truth, and the life, and the true vine. Jesus told Nicodemus that he must be born again, offered living water to a Samaritan woman, healed a blind man, and raised Lazarus. He said "Before Abraham was, I am," and "I and the Father are one." In the Upper Room he washed his disciples' feet, gave a new commandment, and promised the Holy Spirit, the Helper who would be with them forever. He taught them to abide in the vine and prayed for all who would believe through their word. He was arrested, tried, and crucified, saying "It is finished," and was raised on the third day. He called Mary by name, drew Thomas from doubt to worship, and restored Peter. Along the way you doctrinally paused on the incarnation, regeneration, and worship, and prayed through Psalms 36, 139, 119, 43, 23, 100, and 103, which gave voice to the light, the shepherd, and the steadfast love at the heart of this Gospel.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does the Prologue teach about the identity of Jesus?

Reread John 1:1-18. Notice what it says about the Word's relationship to God, to creation, and to us. Write a few sentences about why it matters that Jesus is both fully God and fully human.

What do the seven "I AM" statements reveal about who Jesus is?

List them: the bread of life (6:35), the light of the world (8:12), the door (10:9), the good shepherd (10:11), the resurrection and the life (11:25), the way, the truth, and the life (14:6), and the true vine (15:1). Choose the one that speaks most to your need right now and say why.

What does the Upper Room Discourse teach about the Holy Spirit?

Look at John 14:16-26, 15:26-27, and 16:7-15. What does the Spirit do for believers and for the world? Why did Jesus say it was to their advantage that he go away?

What does "abiding in the vine" look like in everyday Christian life?

Reread John 15:1-17. Think about concrete practices of abiding, such as prayer, Scripture, obedience, and fellowship. Describe one change you could make this week to stay more connected to Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for loving the world so much that he gave his Son.

Thank him for what John has shown you of Jesus.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

DAY 665 · WEEK 95

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 17 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read John 20:31 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."

JOHN 20:31

REST

Meditation

John writes these words at the end of his Gospel, and they tell us why he wrote it. It is the key to reading everything else in the book.

"These are written." The Gospel is a written testimony, chosen from many things Jesus did. John, who saw and heard, put down what we need to know.

"So that you may believe." The purpose is faith. John does not write only to inform us. He writes to bring us to trust in Jesus.

"That Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God." Two titles sum up the content of faith: Christ, the promised king and Savior of Israel, and Son of God, the one who shares the nature of the Father. To believe both is to believe the gospel.

"And that by believing." Faith is the means, not the cause. We are not saved by our faith as a work, but through faith in a person.

“You may have life in his name.” The result is life: forgiveness, new birth, the Spirit, and eternal life, all in the name of Jesus. “In his name” means in the authority and character of his person.

When you wonder what the point of all this reading is, say this verse. It is for you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week Jesus taught you to abide in the true vine, because apart from him you can do nothing, and promised the Helper, the Spirit of truth. In the High Priestly Prayer you overheard the Son pray for you, that you would know the only true God, be kept from the evil one, be sanctified by the truth, and be one with his people. You followed Jesus through the garden, the trials before Annas, Caiaphas, and Pilate, and to the cross, where he said “It is finished.” You saw the burial by Joseph and Nicodemus, and the empty tomb. You heard him call Mary by name, watched Thomas confess “My Lord and my God,” and listened as Jesus restored Peter with three questions about love. You finished the Gospel of John and stated its purpose: that you may believe and have life in his name.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said, “Apart from me you can do nothing.” Where have you been trying to bear fruit on your own, and what would it look like to abide instead?

On the cross, Jesus said, “It is finished.” How does knowing that the work of salvation is complete change the way you live with your guilt and your efforts?

Jesus restored Peter after his denial and gave him a calling. What failure do you need to bring to Jesus, and what would it look like to hear him say “Follow me”?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for the vine, the prayer, the cross, and the empty tomb.

Thank him for writing these things so that you may believe.

Rest in him.

Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 18 · DAYS 666-686

The New Covenant Inaugurated: Mark

Mark 1-16

The servant King acts. Urgency, authority, and the suffering Son of Man.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."

MARK 10:45

Psalms read beside Mark's stories: 107:23-43 (the storm), 89 (the Davidic king), 118:19-29 (the cornerstone), and 69 (the righteous sufferer).

UNIT 18

In this unit

WEEK 96

666	Mark 1:1-45	*Reading*
667	Mark 1:14-15; Luke 17:20-21; 1 Corinthians 15:20-28	*Doctrine*
668	Mark 2:1-3:35	*Reading*
669	Mark 4:1-5:43	*Reading*
670	Mark 6:1-56	*Reading*
671	Psalm 107:23-43	*Psalm*
672	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 97

673	Psalm 89:1-18	*Psalm*
674	Mark 7:1-8:38	*Reading*
675	Mark 9:1-50	*Reading*
676	Mark 10:1-52	*Reading*
677	Mark 11:1-12:44	*Reading*
678	Mark 13:1-37	*Reading*
679	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 98

680	Psalm 118:19-29	*Psalm*
681	Psalm 69:1-21	*Psalm*
682	Mark 14:1-52	*Reading*
683	Mark 14:53-15:20	*Reading*
684	Mark 15:21-47	*Reading*
685	Mark 16:1-20	*Reading*
686	Review and Reflection	*Review and Sabbath*

DAY 666 · WEEK 96

Mark 1:1-45

"Immediately", the Kingdom arrives with authority

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 45 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 1:1-45. Mark begins with no birth story and no prologue. Notice how quickly the scenes move, and how often the word "immediately" appears. Read it in one sitting if you can, to feel the pace.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Mark is the shortest and probably the earliest of the four Gospels. Early Christians said it was written by John Mark, a companion of Peter, and that it reflects Peter's preaching in Rome. It was written for a church that was suffering, and it presents Jesus as the strong Son of God who is also the suffering servant. Mark uses the word "immediately" (or "at once") over forty times. Things happen quickly. There is almost no talk, and much action.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The beginning of the gospel of Jesus Christ, the Son of God" (1:1).
2. "And when he came up out of the water, immediately he saw the heavens being torn open and the Spirit descending on him like a dove" (1:10).
3. "The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel" (1:15).
4. "Follow me, and I will make you become fishers of men" (1:17).
5. "And they were astonished at his teaching, for he taught them as one who had authority, and not as the scribes" (1:22).
6. "And rising very early in the morning, while it was still dark, he departed and went out to a desolate place, and there he prayed" (1:35).

7. “Moved with pity, he stretched out his hand and touched him and said to him, I will; be clean” (1:41).

8. “See that you say nothing to anyone” (1:44).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Mark’s first sentence is his title: “The beginning of the gospel of Jesus Christ, the Son of God.” Gospel means good news, the announcement of a victory. Mark tells us at once who Jesus is, though the people in the story will take most of the book to find out.

John the Baptist appears in the wilderness, as Isaiah promised, and says that one more powerful is coming. Jesus is baptized, and Mark says the heavens are “torn open,” a strong word, as the Spirit descends and the Father says, “You are my beloved Son; with you I am well pleased.” Immediately the Spirit drives him into the wilderness, where he is tempted by Satan for forty days. Mark gives the temptation in two verses. The battle between the Son of God and the powers of darkness has begun.

Then Jesus comes to Galilee: “The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel.” This is the heart of his message. The long-awaited reign of God is arriving in his person. He calls Simon and Andrew, James and John, and they leave their nets at once.

In the synagogue in Capernaum, he teaches with authority, unlike the scribes, who quoted other rabbis. A man with an unclean spirit cries out, “I know who you are, the Holy One of God.” Jesus silences the demon and casts it out. The crowd is amazed. He heals Peter’s mother-in-law, and by evening the whole town is at the door. Yet early the next morning he withdraws to pray. His power flows from communion with the Father.

A leper kneels before him and says, “If you will, you can make me clean.” Moved with pity, Jesus stretches out his hand and touches him, something no one would do, and says, “I will; be clean.” The unclean person is made clean without making Jesus unclean. Then he commands the man to say nothing and to go to the priest. But the man tells everyone. This is the first appearance of a pattern in Mark that scholars call the Messianic secret: Jesus often silences demons and those he heals. We will return to why.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 40:3 and Malachi 3:1 are the prophecies Mark quotes at the start. Psalm 2:7 and Isaiah 42:1 stand behind the voice from heaven. Daniel 7 and Isaiah 52:7 are the background to the kingdom of God. Leviticus 13 and 14 give the laws of leprosy. 1 Peter 5:13 mentions Mark as

Peter's son in the faith. Acts 12:12 and Colossians 4:10 mention John Mark. Romans 1:16 says the gospel is the power of God for salvation.

STEP 6

Application

Read the chapter aloud quickly. How does the pace affect you?

Hear "repent and believe in the gospel" as a daily call, not a once-only event.

Like Jesus, find a quiet place early in the day to pray before the day's demands begin.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Repent and believe in the good news, in your own words.
- Thank Jesus that the kingdom is at hand.
- Ask him to help you follow him immediately.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 96

"The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel."

MARK 1:15

DAY 667 · WEEK 96

Mark 1:14-15; Luke 17:20-21; 1 Corinthians 15:20-28

Inaugurated eschatology

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Doctrine · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 1:14-15, Luke 17:20-21, and 1 Corinthians 15:20-28. Today is a doctrinal pause on the kingdom of God as already here and not yet complete. Notice the tenses: the kingdom has come, and the kingdom will come.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus began his ministry by announcing that the kingdom of God was at hand. The Jews expected the kingdom to arrive all at once, with the Messiah defeating Israel's enemies and raising the dead. Jesus said the kingdom had arrived, and yet he spoke of its future coming. Paul, in 1 Corinthians 15, describes the order of events. Theologians call this "inaugurated eschatology," or the "already and not yet."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Now after John was arrested, Jesus came into Galilee, proclaiming the gospel of God" (Mark 1:14).
2. "The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand" (Mark 1:15).
3. "The kingdom of God is not coming in ways that can be observed" (Luke 17:20).
4. "For behold, the kingdom of God is in the midst of you" (Luke 17:21).
5. "But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep" (1 Corinthians 15:20).
6. "But each in his own order: Christ the firstfruits, then at his coming those who belong to Christ" (1 Corinthians 15:23).

7 “For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet” (1 Corinthians 15:25).

8 “The last enemy to be destroyed is death” (1 Corinthians 15:26).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The kingdom of God is God’s rule and reign over his creation, and in the New Testament it is both present and future. It is present because the King has come. In Jesus’ life, death, and resurrection, the decisive victory over sin, Satan, and death has been won, and the Spirit has been poured out. The powers of the age to come have broken into this age. It is future because the kingdom has not yet come in its fullness. Sin and death still operate, believers still suffer, and Christ’s enemies have not yet been finally put under his feet. The church lives between the first coming and the second, in the overlap of the ages. Biblical scholars call this the “already and not yet.” This framework fits the way the covenants unfold: the promises made to Abraham and David are fulfilled in Christ and have begun to be realized, and they will be completed when he returns. Christians have differed on the details of the end, such as the nature of the millennium in Revelation 20, but all agree that Christ will return, the dead will be raised, and God will be all in all. Until then, the church is not merely waiting. It lives as a sign of the kingdom, proclaiming the King and walking in his ways.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Mark records the opening announcement of Jesus’ public ministry. “The time is fulfilled” means that the long wait, the centuries of promises, is over. “The kingdom of God is at hand” means it has drawn near, in the person of the King. The response is to repent and believe.

Luke 17 shows another side. The Pharisees ask when the kingdom of God will come, and Jesus says it is not coming with signs to be observed. It cannot be pointed to on a map. “The kingdom of God is in the midst of you,” because the King is standing there. The kingdom is first of all a person. His healings and exorcisms are the kingdom’s invasion of the world, and when he casts out demons by the Spirit of God, then the kingdom has come upon them.

Yet the kingdom is not complete. In 1 Corinthians 15, Paul writes of the resurrection and says that Christ is the firstfruits. The firstfruits is the first part of the harvest, and it promises the rest. Christ has been raised, and those who belong to him will be raised at his coming. Then comes the end, when he delivers the kingdom to God the Father after destroying every rule and authority and power. “For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. The last enemy to be destroyed is death.” So there is a reign now, and a final victory yet to come. When all is subjected to him, the Son himself will be subject to the Father, “that God may be all in all.”

This has practical effects. Because the kingdom has come, we have forgiveness, the Spirit, and a new identity, and we can obey. Because it has not fully come, we still groan, suffer, and wait, and we do not expect heaven on earth in this age. We are neither triumphalists nor pessimists. We live with joyful patience, praying "Your kingdom come," and working in hope because we know how the story ends.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 2:44 and 7:13-14 promise an everlasting kingdom. Matthew 12:28 says that if Jesus casts out demons by the Spirit, the kingdom has come. Matthew 6:10 teaches us to pray for the kingdom to come. Romans 8:18-25 describes the groaning of creation as we wait. Hebrews 2:8 says we do not yet see everything in subjection to him. Ephesians 1:13-14 calls the Spirit a guarantee of our inheritance. Revelation 11:15 and 21:1-5 describe the final arrival.

STEP 6

Application

Pray "Your kingdom come" today, thinking of both the ways it has come and the ways it has not.

Where do you see signs of the kingdom in your church or neighborhood? Thank God for them.

When you are discouraged by the world, remember that Christ must reign until every enemy, including death, is under his feet.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that in Jesus the kingdom has come.

Thank him for the firstfruits of the resurrection.

Ask him to teach you to live between the already and the not yet.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 96

“The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel.”

MARK 1:15

DAY 668 · WEEK 96

Mark 2:1-3:35

Controversies; new wineskins; the true family of Jesus

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 63 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 2:1-3:35. A paralyzed man is lowered through a roof, Jesus eats with sinners, the Sabbath controversies begin, and opposition hardens. Notice who Jesus welcomes and who rejects him.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These two chapters contain a series of five conflict stories in Galilee. In each, the religious leaders challenge Jesus' authority: to forgive sins, to eat with sinners, to set aside fasting, and to interpret the Sabbath. By the end of chapter 3, the Pharisees are plotting with the Herodians to destroy him. Mark places the opposition early to show that the road to the cross begins here.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Son, your sins are forgiven" (2:5).
2. "But that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins" (2:10).
3. "Those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick. I came not to call the righteous, but sinners" (2:17).
4. "And no one puts new wine into old wineskins" (2:22).
5. "The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath" (2:27).
6. "And he looked around at them with anger, grieved at their hardness of heart" (3:5).
7. "Whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit never has forgiveness, but is guilty of an eternal sin" (3:29).

8 “For whoever does the will of God, he is my brother and sister and mother” (3:35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Four friends bring a paralyzed man to Jesus, and when they cannot get through the crowd, they dig through the roof. Jesus sees their faith and says to the man, “Son, your sins are forgiven.” The scribes think, “Who can forgive sins but God alone?” They are right about the principle, and that is the point. Jesus then heals the man to prove that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins. The man’s greatest need was forgiveness, and Jesus addressed that first.

He calls Levi, a tax collector, and eats with tax collectors and sinners. When the scribes complain, he says, “Those who are well have no need of a physician.” He has come for the sick. Anyone who thinks they are well will miss him.

When asked why his disciples do not fast, he says the bridegroom is with them. A wedding is no time for fasting. The old way and the new cannot be patched together: new wine requires new wineskins. The new covenant does not fit into the old forms. This is a key statement of the discontinuity in the covenants. What Jesus brings is new.

The Sabbath conflicts follow. His disciples pick grain on the Sabbath, and Jesus says, “The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath. So the Son of Man is lord even of the Sabbath.” In the synagogue he heals a man with a withered hand, and asks whether it is lawful to do good or harm on the Sabbath. They are silent. He looks at them with anger, “grieved at their hardness of heart.” Jesus is angry and sad at the same time. The Pharisees go out and plot with the Herodians how to destroy him.

In chapter 3, crowds follow him, and he appoints twelve to be with him and to be sent out. His family thinks he is out of his mind. The scribes from Jerusalem say he casts out demons by Beelzebul. Jesus responds that a house divided cannot stand, and warns that to attribute the Spirit’s work to Satan is an unforgivable blasphemy, a settled refusal to see God’s work as good. Finally, when his mother and brothers arrive, he looks at those sitting around him and says, “Here are my mother and my brothers! Whoever does the will of God, he is my brother and sister and mother.” The new family of God is defined by obedience to him.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 43:25 says God alone blots out transgressions. Psalm 103:3 says the LORD forgives all your iniquity. Hosea 6:6 is the mercy-over-sacrifice theme. 1 Samuel 21:1-6 is David and the bread. Exodus 20:8-11 and Deuteronomy 5:12-15 are the Sabbath commands. Jeremiah 31:31-

34 promised a new covenant. Hebrews 8:13 says the first covenant is becoming obsolete. Galatians 3:26-29 and Ephesians 2:19 describe the new family of God.

STEP 6

Application

Think of those who brought you to Jesus. Thank God for them, and ask whom you could carry to him.

Reflect on whether you are a patient who needs the physician. Admit your need.

Ask what "doing the will of God" looks like in your family and church this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for authority to forgive sins, and for forgiving yours.

Thank him for coming for sinners.

Ask him to make you new wine, ready for what he is doing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 96

"The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel."

MARK 1:15

DAY 669 · WEEK 96

Mark 4:1-5:43

Parables; the storm; the Gerasene; Jairus's daughter

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 84 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 4:1-5:43. Jesus teaches in parables, stills a storm, frees a demon-possessed man, and heals two women. It is a chapter of authority over the seed, the sea, the spirits, sickness, and death. Notice the repeated question of faith and fear.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus sits in a boat by the Sea of Galilee and teaches a large crowd on the shore. Mark records only a few parables, but they are key to the kingdom. Then comes a day of wonders. Jesus crosses the lake with his disciples, and in the span of two chapters demonstrates his authority over nature, demons, disease, and death.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Listen! Behold, a sower went out to sow" (4:3).
2. "He who has ears to hear, let him hear" (4:9).
3. "It is like a grain of mustard seed, which, when sown on the ground, is the smallest of all the seeds on earth" (4:31).
4. "Peace! Be still!" (4:39).
5. "Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?" (4:41).
6. "Go home to your friends and tell them how much the Lord has done for you, and how he has had mercy on you" (5:19).
7. "Do not fear, only believe" (5:36).
8. "Little girl, I say to you, arise" (5:41).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The parable of the sower is the first of the parables and a key to the rest. A sower scatters seed on four kinds of ground: the path, rocky ground, thorny ground, and good soil. The seed is the word of God. The first three soils show failures: the word is snatched away, withers without roots, or is choked by worries and riches. The good soil hears, accepts, and bears fruit, thirty, sixty, and a hundredfold. Jesus says the parables are given so that those with ears hear, and those without do not understand. They sift. He then tells of the seed growing secretly and the mustard seed. The kingdom starts small, grows by God's power, and ends large.

That evening, Jesus says, "Let us go across to the other side." A great windstorm arises, and the boat is filling with water. Jesus is asleep on a cushion in the stern. The disciples wake him: "Teacher, do you not care that we are perishing?" He rebukes the wind and says to the sea, "Peace! Be still!" There is a great calm. He asks, "Why are you so afraid? Have you still no faith?" And they are filled with great fear and say, "Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?" Their fear of the storm has turned into awe at him.

On the far shore, in Gentile territory, a man lives among the tombs, so possessed that no one can bind him. He is called Legion. Jesus casts the demons into a herd of pigs, and the man is found clothed and in his right mind. The townspeople ask Jesus to leave. The man begs to go with Jesus, but Jesus tells him to go home and tell what the Lord has done. He proclaims it in the Decapolis, ten cities of Gentiles.

Back across the lake, Jairus, a synagogue ruler, begs Jesus to heal his dying daughter. On the way, a woman with a twelve-year flow of blood touches his garment and is healed. Jesus stops and says, "Daughter, your faith has made you well; go in peace." Then news comes that Jairus's daughter is dead. Jesus says, "Do not fear, only believe." He takes her hand and says, "Talitha cumi," "Little girl, I say to you, arise." She gets up and walks. Jesus is the Lord of life.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 55:10-11 says the word will not return empty. Ezekiel 17:22-24 and Daniel 4:10-12 use the image of a great tree. Psalm 65:7, 89:9, and 107:29 show the LORD stilling the sea. Jonah 1 is another storm and sleeping man. Isaiah 65:4 mentions tombs and swine. Leviticus 15:25-30 describes the uncleanness of the woman's bleeding. 2 Kings 4 tells of Elisha raising a child. 1 Corinthians 15:26 says the last enemy to be destroyed is death.

STEP 6

Application

Ask which soil you are right now. What thorns might be choking the word in you?

Name a storm you face, and hear Jesus say “Peace! Be still!” to it.

Like the healed man, tell someone what the Lord has done for you this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to make your heart good soil.
- Tell Jesus about a storm you are in.
- Thank him that he is Lord of both.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 96

“The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel.”

MARK 1:15

DAY 670 · WEEK 96

Mark 6:1-56

Nazareth; the Twelve; John beheaded; the feeding; walking on water

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 6:1-56. Jesus is rejected in Nazareth, sends out the Twelve, John the Baptist is beheaded, five thousand are fed, and Jesus walks on the sea. Notice the contrast between those who reject Jesus and those who receive him.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus returns to his hometown of Nazareth, where he grew up, and meets disbelief. He sends the Twelve out on mission. While they are gone, Mark inserts the story of John's death, a dark foreshadowing of Jesus' own. When the Twelve return, Jesus feeds a crowd of five thousand, and that night walks on water. Mark often sandwiches one story within another to draw out meaning.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "A prophet is not without honor, except in his hometown and among his relatives and in his own household" (6:4).
2. "And he marveled because of their unbelief" (6:6).
3. "And he called the twelve and began to send them out two by two" (6:7).
4. "So they went out and proclaimed that people should repent" (6:12).
5. "When he went ashore he saw a great crowd, and he had compassion on them, because they were like sheep without a shepherd" (6:34).
6. "And taking the five loaves and the two fish he looked up to heaven and said a blessing and broke the loaves" (6:41).
7. "Take heart; it is I. Do not be afraid" (6:50).

8 “For they did not understand about the loaves, but their hearts were hardened” (6:52).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Nazareth, the people who know Jesus best cannot see who he is. “Is not this the carpenter, the son of Mary?” They take offense at him. Jesus says, “A prophet is not without honor, except in his hometown.” Mark says, “He could do no mighty work there,” except to heal a few. Familiarity and unbelief closed their eyes, and “he marveled because of their unbelief.” Even Jesus was astonished at the hardness of human hearts.

He sends out the Twelve two by two with authority over unclean spirits, with only a staff and sandals. They proclaim repentance, cast out demons, and anoint the sick with oil. The mission of Jesus is multiplied through his disciples.

Mark then tells of Herod’s birthday banquet. Herod had imprisoned John for condemning his marriage to his brother’s wife. Herodias holds a grudge, and when her daughter dances and pleases Herod, he rashly promises her anything. At her mother’s request she asks for John’s head on a platter. Herod is distressed but keeps his oath, and John is beheaded. The faithful prophet dies at the whim of a weak king. It is the shadow of the cross.

When the apostles return, Jesus takes them to a desolate place to rest, but a crowd runs ahead. Seeing them, he has compassion because they are like sheep without a shepherd. He teaches, and when evening comes, the disciples suggest sending them away. Jesus says, “You give them something to eat.” They have five loaves and two fish. He looks up to heaven, blesses and breaks, and gives to the disciples to distribute. All eat and are satisfied, with twelve baskets left. It echoes the LORD feeding Israel in the wilderness and Elisha’s miracle, but it is greater.

That night the disciples are straining at the oars against the wind. Jesus comes to them, walking on the sea. “He meant to pass by them.” This is the language of a theophany, like God passing by Moses. They think he is a ghost. He says, “Take heart; it is I. Do not be afraid,” and the wind ceases. Mark comments that they were astonished, for they had not understood about the loaves, “but their hearts were hardened.” They saw but did not see. Mark is preparing for the question in chapter 8: who is Jesus?

STEP 5

Connection

Numbers 27:17 and Ezekiel 34 speak of sheep without a shepherd. Psalm 23 shows the shepherd providing a table. Exodus 16 and 2 Kings 4:42-44 record bread in the wilderness. Job 9:8 says God alone treads on the waves of the sea. Exodus 33:19-23 and 34:6 are God

passing by Moses. Isaiah 43:2 and Psalm 77:19 speak of God's path through the waters. Hebrews 11:36-38 mentions the faithful who suffered.

STEP 6

Application

Is there someone close to you who has trouble seeing Jesus because they know you too well? Pray for them.

Look at the little you have, your five loaves, and offer it to Jesus.

When you are rowing against the wind, listen for "Take heart; it is I."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess where your heart has been hard like those who rejected him.

Ask him to teach you to trust him on the water.

Thank him for feeding you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 96

"The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel."

MARK 1:15

DAY 671 · WEEK 96

Psalm 107:23-43

God stills the storm

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 107:23-43. This is the middle of a great psalm of thanksgiving for God's rescue. Read the storm at sea (vv. 23 to 32) and notice how it echoes Mark 4. You first met Psalm 107 as a song of those brought back from exile; today you look at its sea-storm section alone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 107 describes four groups of people whom the LORD rescued: wanderers in the desert, prisoners, the sick, and sailors. Each cries to the LORD in trouble, he delivers them, and the refrain says they should give thanks. Today's reading covers the fourth group, the sailors in the storm, and then a closing section on how God reverses fortunes. It sits well with the stilling of the storm in Mark 4 and the walk on water in Mark 6.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "They saw the deeds of the LORD, his wondrous works in the deep" (v. 24).
2. "For he commanded and raised the stormy wind, which lifted up the waves of the sea" (v. 25).
3. "They reeled and staggered like drunken men and were at their wits" end' (v. 27).
4. "Then they cried to the LORD in their trouble, and he delivered them from their distress" (v. 28).
5. "He made the storm be still, and the waves of the sea were hushed" (v. 29).
6. "Then they were glad that the waters were quiet, and he brought them to their desired haven" (v. 30).

7. “Let them thank the LORD for his steadfast love, for his wondrous works to the children of men!” (v. 31).

8. “Whoever is wise, let him attend to these things; let them consider the steadfast love of the LORD” (v. 43).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sailors go down to the sea in ships, doing business on the great waters. They see the wonders of the LORD in the deep. But the same God who made the sea can raise the storm. “For he commanded and raised the stormy wind.” The storm is not outside his control. The waves lift them to heaven and drop them to the depths, and “their courage melted away in their evil plight.” They reel like drunken men and are at their wits’ end. The Hebrew says their wisdom was swallowed up. There is nothing left that they can do.

“Then they cried to the LORD in their trouble, and he delivered them from their distress.” It is the simplest and most powerful pattern of the psalm. When we reach the end of ourselves, we can cry to him. “He made the storm be still, and the waves of the sea were hushed.” The word for still is the word for a whisper. At his command the storm becomes a murmur. “Then they were glad that the waters were quiet, and he brought them to their desired haven.”

Compare Mark 4. The disciples, some of them seasoned fishermen, were at their wits’ end. They cried out. And Jesus stood and said, “Peace! Be still!” The disciples asked, “Who is this?” Psalm 107 supplies the answer: this is the LORD who commands the stormy wind and makes the storm be still. Only God does that, and Jesus does it.

The refrain returns: “Let them thank the LORD for his steadfast love.” Thanksgiving is the right response to rescue. Let them extol him in the congregation of the people.

The last verses show a God who turns rivers into a desert and a desert into pools of water, who lifts the needy out of affliction and makes their families like flocks. The upright see it and are glad, and iniquity shuts its mouth. The final line asks us to be wise: consider the steadfast love of the LORD.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 65:7 and 89:9 speak of the LORD stilling the sea. Jonah 1:4-16 describes a storm that stops at God’s word. Job 38:8-11 shows God setting limits to the sea. Isaiah 43:2 promises to be with us through the waters. Mark 4:35-41 and Matthew 8:23-27 are the stilling of the storm. Acts 27 describes Paul’s storm at sea. Hebrews 6:19 calls hope an anchor for the soul.

STEP 6

Application

Where are you at your wits' end? Cry to the LORD in it, as the sailors did.

After a deliverance, remember to give thanks. Write down a recent rescue and thank him for it.

Read the Mark 4 story again beside this psalm, and ask who Jesus must be to do what only God can do.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry to God from your own storm.
- Thank him for stilling the storm to a whisper.
- Thank him for bringing you to your desired haven.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 96

"The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel."

MARK 1:15

DAY 672 · WEEK 96

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Mark 1:15 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel."

MARK 1:15

REST

Meditation

These are the first recorded words of Jesus' public ministry in Mark, and they sum up his whole message.

"The time is fulfilled." The waiting is over. For centuries the prophets had promised a day when God would rescue his people and rule. That day has arrived. Everything in the Old Testament was moving toward this moment.

"And the kingdom of God is at hand." The kingdom is God's reign. It is near, not as an idea, but as a person. The King is standing in Galilee.

"Repent." To repent is to change direction, to turn from sin and self toward God. It is not just feeling sorry. It is a change of mind that leads to a change of life.

"And believe in the gospel." To believe is to trust. The gospel is the good news that the King has come to save. The proper response to good news is to receive it with trust.

Notice the two verbs go together. We repent and believe. They are two sides of one turning. This is how a Christian life begins, and it is how it continues.

When you wonder where to begin each day, say this verse. Turn to him again.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the Gospel of Mark, the fast-moving account of the servant King. In chapter 1 you saw Jesus baptized, tempted, and announcing that the kingdom of God is at hand. Your doctrinal pause on the kingdom taught you to see it as already here and not yet complete. In chapters 2 and 3 he forgave a paralyzed man, ate with sinners, and said new wine needs new wineskins. In chapters 4 to 6 you watched him teach about the seed, still a storm, free a demoniac, raise Jairus's daughter, be rejected in Nazareth, and feed five thousand. Psalm 107 helped you hear the stilling of the storm as the LORD's own work. Through it all, Mark kept asking who this is.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus began his ministry with the words "Repent and believe in the gospel." What does repenting and believing look like in the details of your life this week?

The kingdom is both already here and not yet complete. Where do you see signs of it now, and where are you still waiting?

The disciples asked "Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?" How would you answer that question after what you have read this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Repent and believe the gospel, in your own words.

Thank Jesus for his authority.

Rest in his kingdom.

DAY 673 · WEEK 97

Psalm 89:1-18

I will sing of the steadfast love of the LORD

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 89:1-18. The psalmist sings of God's steadfast love and his covenant with David. Read it with Mark's question in mind: who is the Son of David?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 89 is a maskil of Ethan the Ezrahite. It was probably written after the Davidic dynasty fell, since the second half (which we do not read today) laments that God seems to have rejected his anointed. But the first half sings of God's faithfulness and the covenant promise to David. Reading this part prepares us for Mark, where the question of David's son and the Christ is about to be asked directly.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will sing of the steadfast love of the LORD, forever; with my mouth I will make known your faithfulness to all generations" (v. 1).
2. "You have said, I have made a covenant with my chosen one; I have sworn to David my servant" (v. 3).
3. "I will establish your offspring forever, and build your throne for all generations" (v. 4).
4. "For who in the skies can be compared to the LORD?" (v. 6).
5. "O LORD God of hosts, who is mighty as you are, O LORD, with your faithfulness all around you?" (v. 8).
6. "Righteousness and justice are the foundation of your throne; steadfast love and faithfulness go before you" (v. 14).

7. “Blessed are the people who know the festal shout, who walk, O LORD, in the light of your face” (v. 15).

8. “For our shield belongs to the LORD, our king to the Holy One of Israel” (v. 18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a vow to sing. “I will sing of the steadfast love of the LORD, forever.” Notice the two words that run through the whole psalm: steadfast love and faithfulness. They appear again and again. Ethan sings that God’s love is built up forever and his faithfulness is established in the heavens.

Then comes the covenant. God said, “I have made a covenant with my chosen one; I have sworn to David my servant: I will establish your offspring forever, and build your throne for all generations.” These words echo 2 Samuel 7, the promise of a son of David whose throne would last forever. The psalmist rests the whole praise on this promise.

The psalm then lifts our eyes to the greatness of the LORD. The heavens praise his wonders, and in the assembly of the holy ones he is feared. No one among the heavenly beings is like him. He rules the raging of the sea, and when its waves rise, he stills them. Rahab, the sea monster, he crushed. The heavens and the earth are his, the north and the south he created. His arm is mighty, his hand strong. Here again is the Psalm 107 theme: the LORD stills the sea, and in Mark, Jesus does the same.

Verse 14 gives the foundation of God’s throne: “Righteousness and justice are the foundation of your throne; steadfast love and faithfulness go before you.” God’s rule is not arbitrary. It is built on righteousness, and it is led by love. Blessed are the people who know the festal shout and walk in the light of his face. They rejoice in his name all day and are exalted in his righteousness. Their shield, their king, belongs to the LORD.

Read the psalm in light of Mark 8 to 12. Peter will say, “You are the Christ,” and Bartimaeus will cry, “Son of David, have mercy on me!” The promise of 2 Samuel 7 is held in the hands of the one the Gospel names as the Son of David. When the second half of the psalm asks, “Where is your steadfast love of old, which by your faithfulness you swore to David?”, the answer is Jesus. The throne of David is established forever, in the risen Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Samuel 7:8-16 and 1 Chronicles 17 give the Davidic covenant. Psalm 132:11-18 repeats the oath to David. Psalm 110 speaks of the Lord’s king at his right hand. Isaiah 9:6-7 promises an everlasting throne. Luke 1:32-33 echoes Psalm 89 in the angel’s words to Mary. Acts 2:29-36

says David's promised descendant is the risen Jesus. Romans 1:3-4 says Jesus was descended from David and declared Son of God by the resurrection. Revelation 22:16 calls Jesus the root and descendant of David.

STEP 6

Application

Sing or speak aloud the opening vow: "I will sing of the steadfast love of the LORD, forever." Tell someone of God's faithfulness this week.

Notice that the foundation of God's rule is righteousness and justice. How does that comfort you when the world feels unjust?

Pray for the people of God to walk in the light of his face.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Sing of God's steadfast love, in your own words.
- Thank him for his covenant with David.
- Ask him to help you make known his faithfulness to those who come after you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 97

"And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes."

MARK 9:23

DAY 674 · WEEK 97

Mark 7:1-8:38

Defilement; the Syrophoenician woman; Peter's confession

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 75 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 7:1-8:38. Jesus teaches about what defiles, heals a Gentile woman's daughter, feeds four thousand, and then asks his disciples, "Who do you say that I am?" This is the turning point of the Gospel. Read Peter's confession and what follows slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Pharisees and scribes come from Jerusalem to challenge Jesus about ceremonial washing. He turns the conversation to the heart. Then he travels north into Gentile territory, Tyre, Sidon, and the Decapolis, and heals Gentiles. Mark 8:27-30 is the center of the Gospel. The first half asks, who is this? The second half answers, the Christ who must suffer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "This people honors me with their lips, but their heart is far from me" (7:6).
2. "There is nothing outside a person that by going into him can defile him, but the things that come out of a person are what defile him" (7:15).
3. "Yes, Lord; even the dogs under the table eat the children's crumbs" (7:28).
4. "He has done all things well. He even makes the deaf hear and the mute speak" (7:37).
5. "But who do you say that I am?" Peter answered him, "You are the Christ" (8:29).
6. "And he began to teach them that the Son of Man must suffer many things and be rejected by the elders and the chief priests and the scribes and be killed, and after three days rise again" (8:31).
7. "If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me" (8:34).

8 “For what does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul?” (8:36).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Pharisees ask why Jesus’ disciples eat with unwashed hands. Jesus quotes Isaiah: “This people honors me with their lips, but their heart is far from me.” They have set aside the commandment of God to hold to human tradition. Then he teaches the crowd that it is not what goes into a person that defiles him but what comes out of the heart: evil thoughts, sexual immorality, theft, murder, adultery, covetousness. The problem is not external but internal. Mark adds a parenthetical comment: “Thus he declared all foods clean.” The Old Testament dietary laws, which marked Israel off from the nations, have fulfilled their purpose.

Jesus goes to Tyre, where a Syrophoenician woman, a Gentile, begs him to cast a demon out of her daughter. He says, “Let the children be fed first,” meaning Israel has priority in the history of salvation. She answers with great faith and wit: “Yes, Lord; yet even the dogs under the table eat the children’s crumbs.” Jesus says, “For this statement you may go your way; the demon has left your daughter.” She would not be turned away. Then he heals a deaf man, and the crowd says, “He has done all things well.” He feeds four thousand, probably Gentiles, and warns the disciples about the leaven of the Pharisees.

Then comes the turning point. At Caesarea Philippi, Jesus asks, “Who do people say that I am?” They give the answers: John, Elijah, one of the prophets. Then, “But who do you say that I am?” Peter answers, “You are the Christ.” This is the first time any human in Mark names Jesus rightly. And Jesus immediately begins to teach what kind of Christ he is: one who must suffer, be rejected, be killed, and rise again.

Peter takes him aside and rebukes him. Jesus turns, looks at his disciples, and says to Peter, “Get behind me, Satan! For you are not setting your mind on the things of God, but on the things of man.” Peter wanted a Messiah without a cross. Jesus insists on the cross, and calls everyone who follows him to the same road: “Let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me.” For whoever loses his life for the sake of Jesus and the gospel will save it. “For what does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul?”

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 29:13 is the verse Jesus quotes. Leviticus 11 gives the dietary laws, and Acts 10:9-16 and Romans 14:14 show that they are no longer binding. Jeremiah 17:9 says the heart is deceitful. Isaiah 35:5-6 promises the deaf will hear. Psalm 118:22 and Isaiah 53 point to the rejected,

suffering Messiah. Luke 9:23-25 and Matthew 16:24-26 are parallels to the call to take up the cross. Galatians 2:20 says we have been crucified with Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your heart is far from God even as your lips honor him. Confess it.

Take Peter's confession as your own: "You are the Christ." Then ask whether you are willing to follow the Christ who suffers.

Learn from the Syrophoenician woman's persistence in prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess who you believe Jesus is.
- Ask him to purify your heart.
- Thank him for hearing people like the Syrophoenician woman.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 97

"And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes."

MARK 9:23

DAY 675 · WEEK 97

Mark 9:1-50

The Transfiguration; the demonized boy; greatness in the Kingdom

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 9:1-50. The Transfiguration, a father's honest cry, a second prediction of the passion, and teaching on greatness and sin. Read verses 14 to 29 slowly, the story of the father and his son.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Six days after Peter's confession, Jesus takes Peter, James, and John up a high mountain, and there they see his glory. They come down to find the other disciples in a dispute over a boy they could not heal. Throughout the chapter, the disciples do not understand. Jesus speaks again of his death, and they argue about who is the greatest.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "This is my beloved Son; listen to him" (9:7).
2. "And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes" (9:23).
3. "I believe; help my unbelief!" (9:24).
4. "This kind cannot be driven out by anything but prayer" (9:29).
5. "The Son of Man will be delivered into the hands of men, and they will kill him. And when he is killed, after three days he will rise" (9:31).
6. "If anyone would be first, he must be last of all and servant of all" (9:35).
7. "Whoever causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin, it would be better for him if a great millstone were hung around his neck and he were cast into the sea" (9:42).
8. "Have salt in yourselves, and be at peace with one another" (9:50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

On the mountain, Jesus is transfigured. His clothes become radiant, whiter than anyone could bleach them. Elijah and Moses appear and talk with him. Peter, terrified, suggests building three tents. A cloud overshadows them, and a voice from the cloud says, "This is my beloved Son; listen to him." Suddenly they see only Jesus. The Law (Moses) and the Prophets (Elijah) bear witness to Jesus, and then they fade. The Father's command is to listen to the Son. On the way down, Jesus tells them not to tell anyone until the Son of Man has risen from the dead. They do not understand what rising from the dead means.

At the foot of the mountain, a father has brought his son, who has a spirit that seizes him, throws him down, and makes him mute. The disciples could not cast it out. The father says to Jesus, "If you can do anything, have compassion on us and help us." Jesus says, "If you can! All things are possible for one who believes." And the father cries out one of the most honest prayers in the Bible: "I believe; help my unbelief!" He has faith, but it is mixed with doubt, and he brings both to Jesus. Jesus does not reject him. He rebukes the spirit, and the boy is freed. When the disciples ask why they could not, Jesus says, "This kind cannot be driven out by anything but prayer."

Jesus again speaks of his death and resurrection, and they do not understand and are afraid to ask. Instead, on the road they have argued about who is greatest. Jesus sits down, calls the Twelve, and says, "If anyone would be first, he must be last of all and servant of all." He takes a child in his arms and says that whoever receives such a child in his name receives him.

The chapter ends with stern warnings. John reports someone casting out demons in Jesus' name who was not following them, and Jesus says, "Whoever is not against us is for us." Then he warns against causing little ones to stumble, and calls his followers to take radical action against sin: if your hand or foot or eye causes you to sin, cut it off or pluck it out. The point is not self-mutilation but the seriousness of sin. "Have salt in yourselves, and be at peace with one another."

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 24:15-18 and 34:29-35 describe Moses on the mountain in glory. Malachi 4:5 promises Elijah. Deuteronomy 18:15 says to listen to the prophet like Moses. 2 Peter 1:16-18 is Peter's reflection on the Transfiguration. Luke 9:31 says Moses and Elijah spoke of his departure. Psalm 73:23-26 is a prayer of the weak but trusting. Jude 22 calls us to have mercy on those who doubt. Philippians 2:3-8 shows the servant attitude.

STEP 6

Application

Pray the father's prayer from your heart: "I believe; help my unbelief!" Be honest about both.

Listen to Jesus today. Read one of his teachings in the Gospels slowly.

Ask where you have been arguing about greatness, and take the servant's place.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you listen to his beloved Son.
- Say, "I believe; help my unbelief."
- Ask him to teach you to pray.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 97

"And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes."

MARK 9:23

DAY 676 · WEEK 97

Mark 10:1-52

Divorce; children; the rich man; Bartimaeus

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 10:1-52. Teaching on marriage and divorce, welcoming children, the rich man who walked away, the third prediction of the passion, a request for places of honor, and the healing of Bartimaeus. Verse 45 is the key verse of the Gospel and the memory verse of this unit.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is on the way to Jerusalem. In this chapter, he teaches on the foundations of life in the kingdom: marriage, children, wealth, and power. Each teaching reverses the world's values. And each is followed by a picture of the cross: "The Son of Man came to serve and to give his life." The chapter ends with a blind man who sees, just before the final approach to Jerusalem.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "What therefore God has joined together, let not man separate" (10:9).
2. "Let the children come to me; do not hinder them, for to such belongs the kingdom of God" (10:14).
3. "You lack one thing: go, sell all that you have and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven; and come, follow me" (10:21).
4. "With man it is impossible, but not with God. For all things are possible with God" (10:27).
5. "Whoever would be great among you must be your servant" (10:43).

6. “For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many” (10:45).
7. “Jesus, Son of David, have mercy on me!” (10:47).
8. “Go your way; your faith has made you well” (10:52).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Pharisees test Jesus on divorce. He points back to creation: from the beginning, God made them male and female, and the two become one flesh. “What therefore God has joined together, let not man separate.” Moses permitted divorce because of hardness of heart, but that was not God’s original design. In the house, he tells the disciples that divorce and remarriage amount to adultery. Christians have differed on how to apply this in painful situations, but the high view of marriage is clear.

Parents bring their children for Jesus to touch, and the disciples rebuke them. Jesus is indignant: “Let the children come to me; do not hinder them.” To receive the kingdom like a child, in dependence, is the only way to enter. He takes them in his arms and blesses them.

A rich man runs up and kneels: “Good Teacher, what must I do to inherit eternal life?” Jesus tests him with the commandments, and the man says he has kept them all. “And Jesus, looking at him, loved him.” Then he says, “You lack one thing: go, sell all that you have and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven; and come, follow me.” The man’s face falls and he goes away sorrowful, for he had great possessions. Jesus does not make this a rule for everyone, but he exposes the idol of this man. It is hard for the rich to enter the kingdom. The disciples are astonished, and ask, “Then who can be saved?” Jesus looks at them: “With man it is impossible, but not with God.” Salvation is God’s work.

For the third time, Jesus tells them plainly what will happen in Jerusalem. And again they miss it. James and John ask for the best seats in his glory. The others are indignant. Jesus gathers them and says that the rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them, “But it shall not be so among you. Whoever would be great among you must be your servant.” Then comes the key verse: “For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.” The word ransom is the price paid to free a slave or captive. Jesus gives his life as the price. The “many” is a Semitic expression for a vast number. This verse is the theological center of Mark, and a statement of substitution.

At Jericho, blind Bartimaeus calls out, “Jesus, Son of David, have mercy on me!” The crowd tries to silence him, and he cries louder. Jesus stops, calls him, and asks, “What do you want me to do for you?” “Rabbi, let me recover my sight.” “Go your way; your faith has made you

well." Immediately he receives his sight and follows Jesus on the way. It is the last healing in Mark, and the first time anyone openly calls Jesus Son of David. The blind man sees what the disciples cannot.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:27 and 2:24 are the creation texts Jesus cites. Deuteronomy 24:1-4 is the Mosaic provision. Isaiah 53:10-12 says the servant makes many to be accounted righteous and bears the sin of many. Psalm 49:7-9 says no one can ransom another. 1 Timothy 2:5-6 says Christ gave himself as a ransom for all. Titus 2:14 and 1 Peter 1:18-19 speak of redemption. Philippians 2:5-8 shows his servant mind. Luke 18:35-43 parallels the story of the blind man.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Mark 10:45. It is the memory verse of the unit. Say it every morning this week.

Ask what you cling to that keeps you from following Jesus fully. Pray over it.

Like Bartimaeus, call out to Jesus when others tell you to be quiet.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for giving his life as a ransom for many.

Tell him what you are tempted to hold on to, like the rich man.

Ask him to open your eyes like Bartimaeus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 97

"And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes."

MARK 9:23

DAY 677 · WEEK 97

Mark 11:1-12:44

The Entry; the Temple; controversies; the widow's offering

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 11:1-12:44. The Entry into Jerusalem, the cursing of the fig tree, the cleansing of the temple, and a series of controversies in the temple courts, ending with the widow's offering. Notice how Jesus answers each question and then asks his own.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Mark has taken ten chapters to bring Jesus to Jerusalem, and now he slows down: more than a third of the Gospel is devoted to this last week. Jesus rides in on a colt, goes into the temple, and curses a fig tree, using it as a sign of judgment on a barren temple. Then he teaches in the temple courts, where various groups try to trap him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hosanna! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord!" (11:9).
2. "Is it not written, My house shall be called a house of prayer for all the nations? But you have made it a den of robbers" (11:17).
3. "Have faith in God" (11:22).
4. "And whenever you stand praying, forgive, if you have anything against anyone, so that your Father also who is in heaven may forgive you your trespasses" (11:25).
5. "The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone" (12:10).
6. "And you shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind and with all your strength" (12:30).
7. "You shall love your neighbor as yourself" (12:31).

8 “Truly, I say to you, this poor widow has put in more than all those who are contributing to the offering box” (12:43).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus sends two disciples for a colt, and he enters Jerusalem to the shouts of the crowd. Mark’s entry is quiet compared to the others. Jesus enters the temple, looks around at everything, and leaves, since it is already late. The next morning he curses a barren fig tree, and then he cleanses the temple, driving out the buyers and sellers. The fig tree is wrapped around the temple scene: Mark places the cursing before and the withering after, so that the barren tree interprets what happens in the temple. The temple was supposed to be a house of prayer for all nations. Instead, the outer court, the only place Gentiles could pray, was filled with commerce. The leaders hear and seek to destroy him.

In the temple courts, they challenge his authority. He answers with a question about John’s baptism, and they cannot answer. Then he tells the parable of the tenants: the owner of a vineyard sends servants, and the tenants beat and kill them, and finally he sends his beloved son, and they kill him. It is clear to the leaders that he is speaking about them. Jesus quotes Psalm 118: “The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone.”

The Pharisees and Herodians ask about paying taxes to Caesar, and the Sadducees ask about the resurrection. Jesus answers both: “Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar’s, and to God the things that are God’s.” And the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob “is not God of the dead, but of the living.” A scribe asks which commandment is the most important. Jesus answers with the Shema and Leviticus 19: love God with all your heart, soul, mind, and strength, and love your neighbor as yourself. The scribe agrees, and Jesus says, “You are not far from the kingdom of God.”

Then Jesus asks his own question: how can the Christ be David’s son, when David himself, in Psalm 110, says, “The Lord said to my Lord, Sit at my right hand”? The answer is that the Christ is both David’s son and David’s Lord. He warns against the scribes who devour widows’ houses and make long prayers for show. And then, in the last scene, he watches people give to the temple treasury. Many rich put in large sums. A poor widow puts in two small copper coins. Jesus calls the disciples: “This poor widow has put in more than all those who are contributing… she out of her poverty has put in everything she had, all she had to live on.” God sees the heart.

STEP 5

Connection

Zechariah 9:9 is the colt. Psalm 118:25-26 is the hosanna. Isaiah 56:7 and Jeremiah 7:11 are the temple verses. Isaiah 5:1-7 is the vineyard. Psalm 110:1 is the Lord at the right hand. Deuteronomy 6:4-5 and Leviticus 19:18 are the great commandments. Micah 7:1 and Hosea 9:10 use the fig tree as a picture of Israel. Exodus 3:6 is the God of Abraham. 2 Corinthians 8:1-5 praises generous giving in poverty.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what has crowded out prayer in your life, in your church. Clear a space.

Say the great commandment aloud: love God with your heart, soul, mind, and strength. Which part is hardest?

Give something sacrificial this week, however small, and know that God sees.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Welcome the King who comes in the name of the Lord.

Ask him to make his church a house of prayer for all nations.

Ask him to help you give your whole self.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 97

"And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes."

MARK 9:23

DAY 678 · WEEK 97

Mark 13:1-37

The Olivet Discourse, be watchful

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 37 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 13:1-37. Jesus predicts the destruction of the temple, speaks of tribulation and false teachers, and describes the coming of the Son of Man. The call throughout is to stay awake. Read it for its pastoral purpose.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

As Jesus leaves the temple, a disciple marvels at the huge stones and buildings. Jesus says that not one stone will be left on another. Later, on the Mount of Olives, four disciples ask, "When will these things be, and what will be the sign?" His answer is the Olivet Discourse. It is one of the most debated passages in the Bible. It seems to speak both of the fall of Jerusalem in AD 70 and of the return of Christ at the end, and interpreters differ on how to divide the two.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Do you see these great buildings? There will not be left here one stone upon another that will not be thrown down" (13:2).
2. "And when you hear of wars and rumors of wars, do not be alarmed. This must take place, but the end is not yet" (13:7).
3. "And the gospel must first be proclaimed to all nations" (13:10).
4. "And you will be hated by all for my name's sake. But the one who endures to the end will be saved" (13:13).
5. "And then they will see the Son of Man coming in clouds with great power and glory" (13:26).

6. “Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away” (13:31).
7. “But concerning that day or that hour, no one knows, not even the angels in heaven, nor the Son, but only the Father” (13:32).
8. “And what I say to you I say to all: Stay awake” (13:37).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus tells the disciples not to be led astray. Many will come in his name, saying “I am he.” Wars and rumors of wars, earthquakes, and famines are “the beginning of the birth pains,” not the end. The disciples will be handed over to councils and beaten in synagogues, and will stand before governors and kings for Jesus’ sake, “to bear witness before them.” The gospel must be proclaimed to all nations. When they are arrested, they are not to worry about what to say, for the Holy Spirit will speak through them. Families will be divided, and they will be hated for his name’s sake. “But the one who endures to the end will be saved.”

Then he speaks of the “abomination of desolation” standing where it ought not to be, a phrase from Daniel. When it appears, those in Judea should flee to the mountains. There will be a tribulation such as has not been since the beginning of creation. This language fits the Roman siege of Jerusalem in AD 70, when the temple was destroyed, and many see a further fulfillment in a final tribulation. He warns again about false christs and false prophets who perform signs.

After that tribulation, the sun will be darkened, the moon will not give its light, and the stars will fall. This is the language of cosmic upheaval, used in the prophets for the fall of nations and the day of the LORD. “And then they will see the Son of Man coming in clouds with great power and glory.” This echoes Daniel 7:13. He will send out the angels and gather his elect from the four winds.

Jesus then gives a lesson from the fig tree: when you see its leaves, you know that summer is near. So when you see these things, know that he is near. “Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away.” The time of the end is hidden: not even the Son knows it, only the Father. Jesus speaks here of his human knowledge.

The conclusion is not a timetable but a command: stay awake. A man going on a journey puts his servants in charge, and commands the doorkeeper to be on watch. The master may come in the evening, at midnight, at cockcrow, or in the morning. “Lest he come suddenly and find you asleep.” It is a call to faithful readiness, not speculation. And note that in the very next chapters, the disciples fall asleep in Gethsemane.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 7:13-14, 9:27, 11:31, and 12:11 are the background to the abomination of desolation and the Son of Man. Isaiah 13:10 and 34:4 use the language of cosmic signs. Joel 2:10 and 2:31 describe the sun and moon darkened. Matthew 24 and 25 and Luke 21 parallel this discourse. 1 Thessalonians 5:1-11 teaches readiness for the day of the Lord. 2 Peter 3:3-13 warns of scoffers and urges holy living. Revelation 1:7 echoes the coming with the clouds.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you are awake or asleep, spiritually. What would it look like to be ready?

When news of wars and disasters comes, remember: “This must take place, but the end is not yet.” Do not be alarmed.

Hold the date-setters at arm’s length, as Jesus did. Focus on faithfulness in your assigned work.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask Jesus to keep you watchful.
- Thank him that his words will never pass away.
- Ask him to keep you from being deceived.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 97

“And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes.”

MARK 9:23

DAY 679 · WEEK 97

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Mark 9:23 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes."

MARK 9:23

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this to a father whose son is tormented. The father had said, "If you can do anything, have compassion on us and help us." Jesus takes his word and turns it back.

"If you can!" Jesus is almost surprised at the doubt in the question. It is not a question of whether Jesus can. The question is whether the father will trust. The "if" belongs not to Jesus' power but to the father's faith.

"All things are possible." This is not a blank check to get whatever we want. It is a statement about the power of God available to those who trust him. All things that fit the will of God are possible, because he is God. The one who stills the storm and raises the dead is able.

"For one who believes." The power is not in our believing but in the one we believe. Faith is the open hand that receives what God gives. Even a small and trembling faith can reach out to a great Savior.

Notice what the father does next. He says, “I believe; help my unbelief!” He does not pretend to a perfect faith. He brings his mixture of faith and doubt to Jesus. And Jesus heals his son.

When you feel your faith is too small, say this verse and then pray the father’s prayer. The weakest faith in the strongest Savior is enough.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the Psalm 89 vow to sing of the steadfast love of the LORD and his covenant with David. In Mark 7 and 8 you saw Jesus teach that it is the heart that defiles, heal a Gentile woman’s daughter, and ask the turning-point question, “Who do you say that I am?” Peter’s answer, “You are the Christ,” was followed by Jesus’ first teaching that the Christ must suffer. You went up the mountain and heard the Father say, “Listen to him.” You heard a father cry, “I believe; help my unbelief!” In Mark 10 you read the key verse: the Son of Man came to serve and give his life as a ransom for many. You met Bartimaeus, then watched the King enter Jerusalem, cleanse the temple, and silence every question. Finally, in the Olivet Discourse, he told you to stay awake.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said he came “to give his life as a ransom for many.” What does it mean that the price of your freedom was his life?

Peter confessed that Jesus is the Christ, and then resisted the idea of a suffering Messiah. Where do you want a Jesus without a cross?

The father prayed, “I believe; help my unbelief!” What belief and what unbelief do you bring to Jesus today?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for giving his life as a ransom for many.

Say, “I believe; help my unbelief.”

Ask him to keep you awake to him.

DAY 680 · WEEK 98

Psalm 118:19-29

The stone the builders rejected

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 118:19-29. This is the climax of the Hallel, the psalms sung at Passover. Jesus quoted verses 22 and 23 about himself in Mark 12, and the crowds shouted verse 26 on Palm Sunday. Read it as the song of the King entering the gate.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 118 is a song of thanksgiving for victory, probably sung in a procession to the temple. The singer has been surrounded by enemies and has been saved by the LORD. Now he comes to the gates of the temple to give thanks. The last stanza, our reading, is full of lines that the New Testament applies to Jesus: the gate, the rejected stone, the day the LORD has made, and the blessed one who comes in the LORD's name.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Open to me the gates of righteousness, that I may enter through them and give thanks to the LORD" (v. 19).
2. "I thank you that you have answered me and have become my salvation" (v. 21).
3. "The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone" (v. 22).
4. "This is the LORD's doing; it is marvelous in our eyes" (v. 23).
5. "This is the day that the LORD has made; let us rejoice and be glad in it" (v. 24).
6. "Save us, we pray, O LORD! O LORD, we pray, give us success!" (v. 25).
7. "Blessed is he who comes in the name of the LORD! We bless you from the house of the LORD" (v. 26).

8 “Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!” (v. 29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The singer approaches the gates of the temple and asks them to open. “This is the gate of the LORD; the righteous shall enter through it.” Only the righteous may enter the presence of God, and the question of who is righteous is raised. The answer will come in Christ. He is the righteous one who enters, and through him we enter.

The singer thanks God for answering and becoming his salvation. The word for salvation is yeshuah, the root of the name Jesus. Then comes the famous line: “The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone.” The builders, perhaps the nations or the leaders, threw away a stone as unfit, and it was exactly the stone that held the building together. Israel, small and despised, was chosen by God. David, the youngest son, was passed over and made king. Above all, Jesus was rejected by the leaders of his people and made the cornerstone of the new temple, the church. He applied this verse to himself in the parable of the tenants (Mark 12:10-11), and Peter applied it in Acts 4:11. “This is the LORD’s doing; it is marvelous in our eyes.” The resurrection and exaltation of the rejected Christ is God’s doing.

“This is the day that the LORD has made; let us rejoice and be glad in it.” Christians have long sung this verse on Easter, the day the LORD made in a special way.

“Save us, we pray, O LORD!” In Hebrew, this is hoshia na, which became “Hosanna.” When the crowd shouted “Hosanna! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord!” on the road to Jerusalem, they were quoting this psalm and treating Jesus as the long-awaited one. Verse 26 declares a blessing on the one who comes, and also on the pilgrims. The psalm calls for a festal procession with branches up to the horns of the altar, the same image as the palms on the road.

The psalm closes where it began: “Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!” Jesus and his disciples most likely sang this psalm at the end of the Last Supper, shortly before he went to be rejected. The song he sang about the rejected stone was about himself.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 28:16 speaks of the tested cornerstone laid in Zion. Matthew 21:42, Mark 12:10-11, and Luke 20:17 record Jesus quoting verse 22. Acts 4:11, Ephesians 2:20-22, and 1 Peter 2:4-8 apply the stone to Christ. Matthew 21:9 and John 12:13 have the crowd quoting verse 26. Matthew

26:30 says they sang a hymn after the Supper. Romans 9:33 and 10:11 speak of the stone and those who believe in him. Revelation 21:22 says the Lamb is the temple.

STEP 6

Application

Pray “This is the day the LORD has made” as you start tomorrow. Choose to rejoice.

Think of a time when something rejected became a blessing in your life. Thank God for it.

Say “Hosanna” today, “Save us, we pray.” Name what needs saving.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to open the gates of righteousness for you.
- Thank Jesus, the stone the builders rejected.
- Thank him that this is the day the LORD has made.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 98

“For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.”

MARK 10:45

DAY 681 · WEEK 98

Psalm 69:1-21

Reproach has broken my heart, the suffering servant

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 69:1-21. A suffering man drowns in trouble, hated without cause, and mocked in his thirst. Notice the lines the New Testament applies to Jesus. Read it with the cross ahead of you.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 69 is a psalm of David. It is one of the most quoted psalms in the New Testament, second only to Psalm 22 and Psalm 110 as a source of passages applied to Jesus. David pictures himself sinking in deep waters, hated by enemies, and abandoned by his family. He is a righteous sufferer. Yet he is also honest about his own sin. Jesus, who had no sin of his own, suffered all these things in a deeper way.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Save me, O God! For the waters have come up to my neck” (v. 1).
2. “More in number than the hairs of my head are those who hate me without cause” (v. 4).
3. “O God, you know my folly; the wrongs I have done are not hidden from you” (v. 5).
4. “For it is for your sake that I have borne reproach, that dishonor has covered my face” (v. 7).
5. “For zeal for your house has consumed me, and the reproaches of those who reproach you have fallen on me” (v. 9).
6. “But as for me, my prayer is to you, O LORD. At an acceptable time, O God, in the abundance of your steadfast love answer me in your saving faithfulness” (v. 13).

7. “Reproaches have broken my heart, so that I am in despair. I looked for pity, but there was none, and for comforters, but I found none” (v. 20).

8. “They gave me poison for food, and for my thirst they gave me sour wine to drink” (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a cry of desperation: “Save me, O God! For the waters have come up to my neck.” David is sinking in deep mud with no foothold. He is weary with crying out, and his eyes grow dim with waiting for God.

His enemies are many and hate him for no reason. “I must restore what I did not steal.” He is being blamed and made to pay for what he did not do. Then, honestly, he admits: “O God, you know my folly; the wrongs I have done are not hidden from you.” He is not claiming to be sinless, but he is claiming to be innocent of the charges against him. He prays that those who hope in God will not be put to shame because of him.

The reason for his suffering is devotion to God: “For it is for your sake that I have borne reproach.” His own family treat him as a stranger. “For zeal for your house has consumed me, and the reproaches of those who reproach you have fallen on me.” The disciples remembered the second half of this verse at the cleansing of the temple (John 2:17), and Paul applied the second half to Christ in Romans 15:3. Jesus bore the reproaches directed at God.

He prays at an acceptable time, in God’s abundant steadfast love, and asks to be rescued from the mire. “Let not the flood sweep over me, or the deep swallow me up.” He asks God to answer and draw near. “You know my reproach, and my shame and my dishonor; my foes are all known to you.”

Then verse 20: “Reproaches have broken my heart, so that I am in despair. I looked for pity, but there was none, and for comforters, but I found none.” The disciples fled in Gethsemane. No one comforted him. And verse 21: “They gave me poison for food, and for my thirst they gave me sour wine to drink.” At the cross, Jesus said, “I thirst,” and was given sour wine. Matthew 27:34 and 48, and John 19:28-30, point back to this psalm.

The rest of the psalm (vv. 22 to 36) includes a harsh call for judgment on the enemies, and it ends in praise and hope. The righteous sufferer will be vindicated. We read the first half today to see the suffering that Jesus took on himself.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 22 and Isaiah 53 are other great psalms and prophecies of the righteous sufferer. John 2:17, 15:25, and 19:28-30 quote or echo this psalm. Romans 15:3 quotes verse 9 and applies it to Christ. Acts 1:20 applies verse 25 to Judas. Matthew 27:34 and 27:48 note the sour wine. Lamentations 3:54 and Jonah 2:3-5 also speak of waters over the head. Hebrews 4:15 says we do not have a high priest who cannot sympathize.

STEP 6

Application

When you feel you are sinking, pray verse 1 and verse 13 as your own.

Consider what it cost Jesus to bear reproach for God's sake. Thank him in specific words.

Ask whether your zeal for God's house is real. Bring it to the Lord in prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry to God about what feels like drowning.
- Thank Jesus for taking the reproach of those who reproached God.
- Ask him to teach you to bear reproach for his sake.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 98

"For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."

MARK 10:45

DAY 682 · WEEK 98

Mark 14:1-52

The anointing; the Supper; Gethsemane; arrest

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 14:1-52. The plot, the anointing at Bethany, the Last Supper, Peter's predicted denial, Gethsemane, and the arrest. Notice the contrast between the woman's love and Judas's betrayal, and between Jesus' prayer and the disciples' sleep.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is two days before Passover. The chief priests are looking for a way to arrest and kill Jesus quietly. Mark again sandwiches stories: the plot frames the anointing, and Peter's predicted denial frames the Supper and Gethsemane. Mark's account is the most raw: the disciples all flee, and a young man runs off naked. This is probably Mark himself.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Leave her alone. Why do you trouble her? She has done a beautiful thing to me" (14:6).
2. "Take; this is my body" (14:22).
3. "This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many" (14:24).
4. "You will all fall away, for it is written, I will strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered" (14:27).
5. "Abba, Father, all things are possible for you. Remove this cup from me. Yet not what I will, but what you will" (14:36).
6. "Watch and pray that you may not enter into temptation. The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak" (14:38).
7. "And he kissed him" (14:45).
8. "And they all left him and fled" (14:50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Bethany, a woman breaks an alabaster flask of costly nard and pours it on Jesus' head. Some are indignant at the waste, saying it could have been sold for three hundred denarii, nearly a year's wages. Jesus says, "Leave her alone. She has done a beautiful thing to me." She has anointed his body beforehand for burial. "Wherever the gospel is proclaimed in the whole world, what she has done will be told in memory of her." Right after this, Judas goes to the chief priests and offers to betray him.

At the Passover meal, Jesus says one of the twelve will betray him, one who is eating with him. They are sorrowful and ask, "Is it I?" He takes bread, blesses it, breaks it, and says, "Take; this is my body." He takes the cup, gives thanks, and says, "This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many." This is the covenant sacrifice, like Moses sprinkling the blood at Sinai (Exodus 24:8). He will not drink again of the fruit of the vine until the day he drinks it new in the kingdom of God. They sing a hymn and go to the Mount of Olives.

On the way he says that they will all fall away, quoting Zechariah 13:7. Peter insists, "Even though they all fall away, I will not," and Jesus tells him that before the rooster crows twice, he will deny him three times. Peter says even more vehemently that he will not deny him, and they all say the same.

In Gethsemane, Jesus is "greatly distressed and troubled" and says, "My soul is very sorrowful, even to death." He falls to the ground and prays, "Abba, Father, all things are possible for you. Remove this cup from me. Yet not what I will, but what you will." Abba is the intimate word for Father. The cup is the wrath of God against sin. Jesus does not want to drink it, and yet he submits. He returns three times to find the disciples sleeping. "The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak." Then: "The hour has come. The Son of Man is betrayed into the hands of sinners."

Judas arrives with a crowd armed with swords and clubs and gives a signal: "The one I will kiss is the man." He kisses him. They seize him. One of the bystanders draws a sword and cuts off the ear of the high priest's servant. Jesus says, "Have you come out as against a robber?" and that this is to fulfill the Scriptures. Then, in Mark's sad phrase, "they all left him and fled." Jesus is utterly alone.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 12 and 24:8 are the Passover and the covenant blood. Jeremiah 31:31-34 promised the new covenant. Zechariah 13:7 is the shepherd struck. Psalm 41:9 predicts the betrayal by a friend. Isaiah 53:5-12 describes the servant who is pierced and who pours out his soul to

death. Psalm 42:5-6 and 116:3 are cries of a soul in distress. Romans 8:15 and Galatians 4:6 say we cry “Abba” by the Spirit. Hebrews 5:7-8 recalls his prayers with loud cries and tears.

STEP 6

Application

Pray “Abba, Father” today and let the word sink in. You are his child.

When you face a hard obedience, pray Jesus’ prayer: “Yet not what I will, but what you will.”

Remember that the Lord’s Supper proclaims his body broken and blood poured out. Receive it with thanks.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the cup Jesus drank for you.
- Thank him for the blood of the covenant poured out for many.
- Pray, “Abba, Father,” and tell him what you want to give him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 98

“For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.”

MARK 10:45

DAY 683 · WEEK 98

Mark 14:53-15:20

Trials; Peter's denial; before Pilate

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 40 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 14:53-15:20. Jesus before the council, Peter's denial, Jesus before Pilate, and the mockery by the soldiers. Notice how little Jesus says, and what he does say.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is taken to the high priest's house, where the whole council assembles at night. Peter follows at a distance and sits in the courtyard. At dawn Jesus is bound and led to Pilate, the Roman governor, since the Jews have no authority to carry out a death sentence. Mark intercuts Jesus' trial and Peter's denial, so that we see the faithful Jesus and the failing Peter at the same moment.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But he remained silent and made no answer" (14:61).
2. "I am, and you will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power, and coming with the clouds of heaven" (14:62).
3. "And he broke down and wept" (14:72).
4. "Are you the King of the Jews?" And he answered him, "You have said so" (15:2).
5. "But Jesus made no further answer, so that Pilate was amazed" (15:5).
6. "For he perceived that it was out of envy that the chief priests had delivered him up" (15:10).
7. "So Pilate, wishing to satisfy the crowd, released for them Barabbas; and having scourged Jesus, he delivered him to be crucified" (15:15).

8 “And they clothed him in a purple cloak, and twisting together a crown of thorns, they put it on him” (15:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The council seeks testimony against Jesus to put him to death, but their witnesses disagree. Some say he threatened to destroy the temple made with hands and build another in three days. Jesus is silent, as Isaiah 53:7 foretold. Finally the high priest asks, “Are you the Christ, the Son of the Blessed?” And Jesus says, “I am.” This is the clearest public statement in Mark. Then he adds that they will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power and coming with the clouds of heaven, combining Psalm 110 and Daniel 7. The high priest tears his clothes and cries blasphemy. They condemn him as deserving death, spit on him, blindfold him, and strike him.

In the courtyard, Peter warms himself by the fire. A servant girl says, “You also were with the Nazarene.” He denies it. Then again. Then bystanders say, “Certainly you are one of them, for you are a Galilean,” and he invokes a curse on himself and swears, “I do not know this man of whom you speak.” Immediately the rooster crows a second time. Peter remembers Jesus’ words, “and he broke down and wept.” The bold disciple has failed. But we know from John 21 that the story does not end here.

In the morning, Jesus is brought to Pilate, who asks, “Are you the King of the Jews?” Jesus says, “You have said so.” The chief priests make many accusations, but Jesus makes no answer, and Pilate is amazed. Pilate knows that the leaders have handed Jesus over out of envy. Each year at the feast, he releases a prisoner. The crowd is stirred up to ask for Barabbas, a rebel and murderer. “Then what shall I do with the man you call the King of the Jews?” “Crucify him!” “Why? What evil has he done?” But they shout more, “Crucify him!” So Pilate, wishing to satisfy the crowd, releases Barabbas, and after flogging Jesus, delivers him to be crucified.

The soldiers take Jesus inside and call the whole battalion. They clothe him in a purple cloak, press a crown of thorns on his head, and salute him mockingly: “Hail, King of the Jews!” They strike his head with a reed, spit on him, and kneel in mock homage. They are mocking the truth. He is the King, and one day every knee will bow. Barabbas goes free, and the innocent Son is condemned. One man was set free because Jesus took his place, as we are.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 53:7 and Psalm 38:13-14 describe the silent sufferer. Daniel 7:13-14 and Psalm 110:1 are the Son of Man and the right hand. Leviticus 24:16 is the penalty for blasphemy. Isaiah 50:6 describes the servant giving his back to those who strike. Psalm 2:1-6 shows the nations raging. Philippians 2:10-11 says every knee will bow. 1 Peter 2:22-24 says he bore our sins. Romans 5:8 says Christ died for us while we were still sinners.

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on Peter's tears. Have you denied Jesus by silence or in words? Let godly sorrow lead you back to him.

Consider the silence of Jesus. Are there times to be silent under accusation?

Thank Jesus that he took the place of Barabbas, and of you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being condemned, mocked, and silent for you.
- Confess where you have denied him.
- Ask him for courage to confess him when it costs.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 98

"For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."

MARK 10:45

DAY 684 · WEEK 98

Mark 15:21-47

The crucifixion, the centurion's confession

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 27 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 15:21-47. The march to Golgotha, the crucifixion, the cry of dereliction, the death, the tearing of the temple curtain, and the centurion's confession. This is the climax of Mark's Gospel. Read slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is led out to Golgotha, the place of the skull. Mark's account is stark. There is no mention of the forgiveness of enemies or the promise to the thief, which Luke records. Instead, Mark gives us the one cry from the cross: "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" Everything in the Gospel has been moving to this point, and the first human to name Jesus rightly at the cross is a Roman soldier.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And they compelled a passerby, Simon of Cyrene, who was coming in from the country, the father of Alexander and Rufus, to carry his cross" (15:21).
2. "And the inscription of the charge against him read, The King of the Jews" (15:26).
3. "He saved others; he cannot save himself" (15:31).
4. "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (15:34).
5. "And Jesus uttered a loud cry and breathed his last" (15:37).
6. "And the curtain of the temple was torn in two, from top to bottom" (15:38).
7. "Truly this man was the Son of God!" (15:39).
8. "Joseph of Arimathea, taking courage, went to Pilate and asked for the body of Jesus" (15:43).

STEP 4

Interpretation

A passerby, Simon of Cyrene, is forced to carry the cross. Mark names his sons, Alexander and Rufus, probably because they were known in the church. Rufus may be the one Paul greets in Romans 16:13. They offer Jesus wine mixed with myrrh, and he refuses it. They crucify him at the third hour, nine in the morning, and divide his garments. Above him is written, "The King of the Jews." Two robbers are crucified with him, one on his right and one on his left.

Passersby mock him: "Aha! You who would destroy the temple and rebuild it in three days, save yourself!" The chief priests and scribes say, "He saved others; he cannot save himself." They speak more truth than they know. He cannot save himself and save us. Even the robbers revile him.

At the sixth hour, noon, darkness comes over the whole land until the ninth hour. Then Jesus cries with a loud voice, "Eloi, Eloi, lema sabachthani?", "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" This is Psalm 22:1. In this moment, the Son bears the curse of sin and experiences the abandonment that sinners deserve. It is the deepest mystery of the cross. The Father did not abandon him because of anything he did, but because of what he bore. Some bystanders think he is calling Elijah. Someone fills a sponge with sour wine, and Jesus gives a loud cry and breathes his last.

The curtain of the temple is torn in two from top to bottom. This is the curtain between the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place. God himself tears it from the top. Access to God's presence is now open through the death of Jesus.

Then the centurion, standing in front of Jesus, sees how he died and says, "Truly this man was the Son of God!" The first to confess him as the Son of God at the cross is a Gentile soldier, one of those who had mocked him. This is the high point of Mark. The book began, "The beginning of the gospel of Jesus Christ, the Son of God." The secrecy is over. It is at the cross that we see who he really is.

Women, including Mary Magdalene, are watching from afar, and Joseph of Arimathea, a respected member of the council who was looking for the kingdom of God, boldly asks for the body and lays it in a tomb cut out of rock. The women see where he is laid.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 22 is the psalm Jesus quotes, and it ends in praise and triumph. Isaiah 53:4-6 says he bore our griefs and was pierced for our transgressions. Amos 8:9 foretold darkness at noon. Exodus 26:31-35 and Hebrews 9:8 and 10:19-20 explain the curtain. Galatians 3:13 says Christ

became a curse for us. 2 Corinthians 5:21 says God made him to be sin for us. Mark 1:1 and 1:11 echo with 15:39. Romans 16:13 mentions Rufus.

STEP 6

Application

Sit with the cry “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” Thank him that he was forsaken so that you never need to be.

Confess with the centurion, “Truly this man was the Son of God.” Say it aloud.

Consider the torn curtain and approach God today, boldly, because of what Jesus has done.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being forsaken so you never will be.
- Thank him for bearing the curse and the wrath.
- Say with the centurion who you believe Jesus is.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 98

“For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.”

MARK 10:45

DAY 685 · WEEK 98

Mark 16:1-20

The resurrection, "He is risen; he is not here"

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 16:1-20. The women find the empty tomb. Note that the earliest manuscripts end at verse 8, and verses 9 to 20 are not found in them. Many Bible translations set those verses apart. Read verses 1 to 8 as Mark's own ending, and then the longer ending as an early summary of the resurrection appearances and the commission.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the Sabbath, early on the first day of the week, Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother of James, and Salome bring spices to anoint Jesus' body. Their question on the way is practical: who will roll the stone away? What they find is an empty tomb and a young man in a white robe. The abrupt ending at verse 8 is deliberate: it leaves the reader to respond. The longer ending (vv. 9 to 20) was added early and summarizes appearances recorded elsewhere.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Who will roll away the stone for us from the entrance of the tomb?" (16:3).
2. "They saw that the stone had been rolled back" (16:4).
3. "Do not be alarmed. You seek Jesus of Nazareth, who was crucified. He has risen; he is not here. See the place where they laid him" (16:6).
4. "But go, tell his disciples and Peter that he is going before you to Galilee" (16:7).
5. "And they went out and fled from the tomb, for trembling and astonishment had seized them, and they said nothing to anyone, for they were afraid" (16:8).
6. "Go into all the world and proclaim the gospel to the whole creation" (16:15).

7 “So then the Lord Jesus, after he had spoken to them, was taken up into heaven and sat down at the right hand of God” (16:19).

8 “And they went out and preached everywhere, while the Lord worked with them and confirmed the message by accompanying signs” (16:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The women wonder how they will move the large stone, and when they look up, they see that it has already been rolled back. Inside the tomb, a young man sits on the right side, dressed in a white robe. The women are alarmed. He says, “Do not be alarmed. You seek Jesus of Nazareth, who was crucified. He has risen; he is not here.” The One who was crucified is the One who is risen. He points to the place where they laid him, empty. Then he gives a message: “Go, tell his disciples and Peter that he is going before you to Galilee. There you will see him, just as he told you.” Notice “and Peter.” The disciple who denied him is not cast aside. He is specifically named.

Then, in the oldest manuscripts, the Gospel ends: “And they went out and fled from the tomb, for trembling and astonishment had seized them, and they said nothing to anyone, for they were afraid.” It is an abrupt ending, but it is powerful. After all that the disciples have done, the final faithful ones, the women, are also afraid. The reader is left with the announcement of the resurrection and the question: what will you do with this? We know the women did tell, because otherwise there would be no Gospel. The book ends where it began, with the good news, and invites us to carry it forward.

Verses 9 to 20, the longer ending, were probably added early. They summarize the appearance to Mary Magdalene, to two disciples on the road, and to the eleven, and give the commission: “Go into all the world and proclaim the gospel to the whole creation. Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved, but whoever does not believe will be condemned.” It ends with Jesus’ ascension and the disciples preaching everywhere with the Lord working with them. Because the status of these verses is uncertain, Christians are wise not to build doctrine or practice on them alone. In particular, the verses about handling serpents and drinking poison (vv. 17 to 18) are not taught elsewhere in the New Testament as normative. The commission itself is confirmed in Matthew 28 and Acts 1.

The resurrection is the proof of everything Jesus said. His claim to be the Christ, his death as a ransom, his promise to rise, all are vindicated. The strong Son of God who died as a servant is alive.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 16:10 and Isaiah 53:10-12 foreshadow the resurrection. Mark 8:31, 9:31, and 10:34 are the three predictions. Mark 14:28 promised he would go before them to Galilee. Matthew 28, Luke 24, and John 20 give the other resurrection accounts. 1 Corinthians 15:3-8 lists the appearances. Acts 1:8-11 records the commission and ascension. Romans 1:4 says he was declared to be the Son of God by his resurrection. 1 Peter 1:3 says we have a living hope through the resurrection.

STEP 6

Application

Say aloud, “He has risen; he is not here.” Let it settle.

Notice the words “and Peter.” Hear Jesus naming you in his forgiveness after your failures.

Don’t stay silent out of fear. Think of one person you can tell about the resurrection this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise Jesus that he is not in the tomb.
- Thank him that the empty tomb proves his work is finished.
- Ask him to send you to tell someone.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 98

“For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.”

MARK 10:45

DAY 686 · WEEK 98

Review and Sabbath Rest

Unit 18 review, The New Covenant Inaugurated, Mark

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Review and Sabbath

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."
>
> MARK 10:45

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this to James and John, who have just asked for the best seats in his coming glory, and to the ten who are indignant. It is the key to the whole Gospel of Mark.

"For even the Son of Man." The Son of Man is the figure of Daniel 7 who receives all authority and an everlasting kingdom. If anyone deserves to be served, it is he. The word "even" marks the surprise.

"Came not to be served." He had every right to be served. He is the Lord of angels. Yet he refused to use his rights for himself. The King does not act like the kings of the Gentiles.

"But to serve." The Servant King washes feet, feeds crowds, heals the sick, touches lepers, and welcomes children. His whole life was service.

"And to give his life." Service reaches its height at the cross. His death was not a defeat but the purpose of his coming. He gave his life. No one took it from him.

"As a ransom for many." A ransom is the price paid to free a prisoner. We were captive to sin, death, and the devil. The price was his life. The "many" means a multitude beyond number, all who trust him.

When you are tempted to seek your own greatness, say this verse. The greatest of all became the servant of all, and he did it for you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read Psalm 118:19-29, the song of the rejected stone that became the cornerstone, and Psalm 69:1-21, the cry of the righteous sufferer whose thirst was met with sour wine. In Mark 14 you saw the woman anoint Jesus for burial, the Supper with its words about the body and the blood of the covenant, and the prayer in Gethsemane: “Abba, Father, yet not what I will, but what you will.” You watched Judas kiss him and the disciples flee. In chapters 14 and 15 you stood by as he was tried, denied by Peter, and flogged. You stood at the cross and heard the cry, “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” and saw the curtain torn in two. A Roman centurion confessed him as the Son of God. Finally, you came to the empty tomb and the announcement, “He has risen.”

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

You have read the Gospel of Mark, the fast-moving account of the servant King. It opened with the announcement that the kingdom of God is at hand, and showed Jesus acting with authority over demons, disease, nature, and death. Your doctrinal pause on the kingdom taught you to see it as already inaugurated and not yet complete. Along the way Jesus forgave sins, ate with sinners, taught in parables, and called his disciples to follow him. Again and again he silenced demons and those he healed, the so-called Messianic secret, because he would be known rightly only at the cross. At Caesarea Philippi, Peter finally confessed, “You are the Christ,” and Jesus began to teach that the Christ must suffer, be killed, and rise. The second half of the Gospel moves steadily toward Jerusalem: the Transfiguration, the passion predictions, the ransom saying of 10:45, Bartimaeus, the Entry, the temple controversies, and the Olivet Discourse. The passion narrative slows to a crawl: the anointing, the Supper, Gethsemane, the arrest, Peter’s denial, the silent King before Pilate, the cry of dereliction, and the torn curtain. A Roman centurion gave the Gospel’s climactic confession, “Truly this man was the Son of God!” And the Gospel ends at an empty tomb, with the message, “He has risen; he is not here.” Your Psalms carried the story: Psalm 107 on the stilling of the storm, Psalm 89 on David’s covenant, Psalm 118 on the rejected stone, and Psalm 69 on the righteous sufferer.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What is the “Messianic secret” in Mark?

Look at 1:25, 1:34, 1:44, 3:12, 5:43, 7:36, 8:30, and 9:9. Why do you think Jesus often commands silence? Consider how the cross changes what it means to call him the Christ, and write a few sentences.

Why does Mark's Gospel move so quickly?

Notice the repeated "immediately" and the short, vivid scenes. What kind of Savior does that pace portray? What would it have meant for a suffering church in Rome to read this Gospel?

How does Mark's Gospel build toward the cross as its climax?

Trace the three passion predictions (8:31, 9:31, 10:33-34), the ransom saying in 10:45, and the proportion of the Gospel given to the final week. How does the centurion's confession in 15:39 answer the question the Gospel has been asking?

What does Mark's Passion narrative add to the other Gospels?

Reread chapters 14 and 15. Notice the starkness: the desertion by all the disciples, the single cry of dereliction, and the absence of any comfort. What do these details teach about the cost of the cross and about following Jesus?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the Gospel of Mark and for the Servant who gave his life as a ransom.

Tell him what you have seen of Jesus.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 19 · DAYS 687-724

The New Covenant Applied: Acts

Acts 1-28

The Spirit comes. The church is born. The gospel reaches the ends of the earth.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."

ACTS 1:8

Psalms 2, 16, and 110, which Peter preaches from, and mission psalms (67, 87, 117, 96, 98, 100).

UNIT 19

In this unit

WEEK 99

687	Acts 1:1-26	*Reading*
688	Acts 1:1-11; Hebrews 4:14-16	*Doctrine*
689	John 14:15-31; John 16:5-15; Acts 2:1-21	*Doctrine*
690	Acts 2:37-41; 2 Corinthians 7:8-11	*Doctrine*
691	Acts 2:42; Romans 10:14-17	*Doctrine*
692	Acts 2:1-47	*Reading*
693	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 100

694	Acts 3:1-4:31	*Reading*
695	Acts 4:32-6:7	*Reading*
696	Psalm 2	*Psalm*
697	Psalm 16	*Psalm*
698	Psalm 110:1-7	*Psalm*
699	Acts 6:8-8:3	*Reading*
700	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 101

701	Acts 8:4-40	*Reading*
702	Acts 9:1-43	*Reading*
703	Acts 10:1-11:30	*Reading*
704	Acts 12:1-13:52	*Reading*
705	Psalm 67	*Psalm*
706	Psalm 87	*Psalm*
707	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 102

708	Psalm 117	*Psalm*

709	Acts 14:1-28	*Reading*
710	Acts 15:1-41	*Reading*
711	Acts 16:1-40	*Reading*
712	Acts 17:1-18:28	*Reading*
713	Acts 19:1-41	*Reading*
714	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 103

715	Acts 20:1-38	*Reading*
716	Psalm 96	*Psalm*
717	Psalm 98	*Psalm*
718	Psalm 100	*Psalm*
719	Acts 21:1-22:30	*Reading*
720	Acts 23:1-24:27	*Reading*
721	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 104

722	Acts 25:1-26:32	*Reading*
723	Acts 27:1-28:31	*Reading*
724	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 687 · WEEK 99

Acts 1:1-26

The ascension; choosing Matthias, preparing for power

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 1:1-26. Luke picks up where his Gospel ended: Jesus appears alive for forty days, promises the Spirit, and ascends. The disciples wait and pray, and a twelfth apostle is chosen. Notice the commission in verse 8, which is also the outline of the whole book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Acts is the second volume of Luke's work, addressed again to Theophilus. If the Gospel tells all that Jesus began to do and teach, Acts tells what he continued to do by his Spirit through his church. It covers about thirty years, from the ascension around AD 30 to Paul's imprisonment in Rome around AD 60. Its title, "Acts of the Apostles," is a little misleading. The main actor is the risen Lord, working by the Holy Spirit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He presented himself alive to them after his suffering by many proofs, appearing to them during forty days and speaking about the kingdom of God" (1:3).
2. "For John baptized with water, but you will be baptized with the Holy Spirit not many days from now" (1:5).
3. "Lord, will you at this time restore the kingdom to Israel?" (1:6).
4. "But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth" (1:8).
5. "He was lifted up, and a cloud took him out of their sight" (1:9).

6. “This Jesus, who was taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you saw him go into heaven” (1:11).
7. “All these with one accord were devoting themselves to prayer” (1:14).
8. “You, Lord, who know the hearts of all, show which one of these two you have chosen” (1:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Luke says that Jesus showed himself alive by “many proofs.” The resurrection was not a vision or a feeling. It was a public fact, and the disciples were eyewitnesses. For forty days he taught them about the kingdom of God. Then he told them not to leave Jerusalem but to wait for the promise of the Father, the baptism with the Holy Spirit.

The disciples ask, “Lord, will you at this time restore the kingdom to Israel?” They are still thinking in terms of a political restoration. Jesus does not rebuke the question, but redirects it. The times are the Father’s business. Their business is to be witnesses, and the power to do it will come from the Spirit. Then comes the outline of Acts: Jerusalem (chapters 1 to 7), Judea and Samaria (8 to 12), and the end of the earth (13 to 28). The gospel will move outward in widening circles.

Then he is lifted up, and a cloud receives him. Two men in white say, “Why do you stand looking into heaven? This Jesus will come in the same way as you saw him go.” The ascension is not an absence. He is enthroned, and he will return. The disciples go back to Jerusalem filled with joy (Luke 24:52), and gather in the upper room with the women, Mary the mother of Jesus, and his brothers. They devote themselves to prayer. This is how a church waits: together, in prayer.

Peter then leads the group to replace Judas. The qualification is that the replacement must have been with them from the baptism of John to the ascension and must be a witness to the resurrection. They propose two men, pray, and cast lots, and the lot falls on Matthias. Christians have differed on whether this was the right choice, since Paul is later called an apostle. But the point is that the Twelve, representing the twelve tribes of renewed Israel, are restored to their number before Pentecost.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 24:47-53 is the end of Luke’s Gospel, with the same promise and ascension. Joel 2:28-29 promised the Spirit. Ezekiel 36:26-27 and Jeremiah 31:33 promised a new heart and the Spirit within. Psalm 110:1 and Daniel 7:13 are the background to the ascension and the cloud.

Isaiah 49:6 is the light to the ends of the earth. Psalm 69:25 and 109:8 are cited for Judas's replacement. Matthew 28:18-20 is the Great Commission.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Acts 1:8 this week. It is the memory verse of the unit.

Wait before you act. Spend time in prayer, with others if you can, before an important decision.

Think about your own Jerusalem, Judea, Samaria, and ends of the earth. Who is in each circle for you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for showing himself alive by many proofs.
- Thank him for the promise of the Spirit.
- Ask him to make you a witness where you are.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 99

"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers."

ACTS 2:42

DAY 688 · WEEK 99

Acts 1:1-11; Hebrews 4:14-16

Christ ascended and reigning

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Doctrine · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 1:1-11 slowly, then turn to Hebrews 4:14-16. Today is a doctrinal pause, so you are reading two passages together: Luke's account of Jesus rising into the clouds, and the author of Hebrews telling us what that ascension means for the weak and weary. Ask as you read: where did Jesus go, and what is he doing there now?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

For forty days after his resurrection, Jesus appeared to his disciples, proving he was alive and teaching them about the kingdom of God. Yesterday's reading closed that season of appearances and opened the book of Acts, which is Luke's second volume. His first volume told what Jesus began to do and teach. Acts tells what he continues to do through his Spirit and his church. But first he must leave. Today we stand on the Mount of Olives with eleven confused men, watching their risen Lord lifted up and taken out of sight. Most Christians celebrate Christmas and Easter. Far fewer know what to do with the ascension. This day exists to correct that, because the ascension is where the story of the resurrection becomes the story of Christ's reign.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Luke calls his Gospel an account of "all that Jesus began to do and teach" (v. 1), which implies that Acts records what Jesus continues to do.
2. Jesus gave "many proofs" that he was alive during forty days (v. 3). The resurrection was physical and public.
3. The disciples ask whether Jesus will now restore the kingdom to Israel (v. 6). They are still thinking in small, national terms.

4. Jesus does not deny the kingdom. He redirects them to the Spirit's power and their witness "to the end of the earth" (vv. 7-8).
5. Jesus is "lifted up" while they are looking, and a cloud takes him from their sight (v. 9).
6. Two men in white tell them Jesus will return "in the same way" as they saw him go (v. 11).
7. Hebrews 4:14 says Jesus "has passed through the heavens." The ascension is described as a journey with a destination.
8. Hebrews 4:15-16 draws a pastoral conclusion: because Jesus sympathizes with weakness, we may draw near to the throne of grace with confidence.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The ascension is the event in which the risen Lord Jesus Christ, in his glorified human body, departed from this earth and was received into heaven, where he now sits at the right hand of the Father. It is both a real event on a real day and the beginning of a real, ongoing ministry. The Apostles' Creed confesses it plainly: "He ascended into heaven and is seated at the right hand of God the Father Almighty."

Scripture gives us several truths about the ascension. First, it was bodily. The same Jesus who ate fish with his disciples was taken up. He did not shed his humanity like a costume once the mission was finished. A man now reigns at the right hand of God, and he will remain a man forever. This is astonishing good news for human beings, because it means our nature has been carried into the presence of God and honored there.

Second, the ascension is enthronement. In the ancient world, to sit at the right hand of a king was to share his authority. Psalm 110:1 anticipates it: "The LORD says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand." Peter will preach in Acts 2 that this is exactly what happened to Jesus. Paul says in Ephesians 1:20-22 that God seated Christ above every rule, authority, power, and dominion, and put all things under his feet. The crucified carpenter is Lord of all. This is why the church can speak with confidence in a hostile world: the throne of heaven is not empty or contested. Christ reigns now, even though the full visible evidence of his reign awaits his return.

Third, the ascension inaugurates his priestly intercession. Hebrews insists that Jesus is our great high priest who has passed through the heavens. Under the old covenant, the high priest entered the Most Holy Place once a year with blood, and then he left. Christ has entered the true heavenly sanctuary with his own blood, and he does not need to leave again. Romans 8:34 says he is "at the right hand of God, who indeed is interceding for us." Your Savior is not distant or indifferent. He is your advocate before the Father right now.

Fourth, the ascension makes the gift of the Spirit possible. Jesus told his disciples it was to their advantage that he go away, because if he did not, the Helper would not come (John 16:7). Pentecost is the ascended Christ pouring out his Spirit on his people (Acts 2:33). The church's power in mission is the power of a reigning king.

Fifth, the ascension guarantees a future. The angels said he will come back in the same way. The ascended Christ is also the returning Christ. Between the ascension and the return, the church lives as a people who are sent. We are not left to guard a memory. We are sent to bear witness to a living king.

Some Christians treat the ascension as an awkward epilogue to Easter, as if Jesus got his body back and then needed to be gotten rid of. Scripture treats it as a coronation. The resurrection shows that death is defeated. The ascension shows that the one who defeated it now rules. If the cross is where Christ paid for sin and the resurrection is where he was vindicated, the ascension is where he took his seat, because the work is finished.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Luke opens Acts by looking back and looking forward. Looking back, he reminds Theophilus that his first book dealt with "all that Jesus began to do and teach until the day when he was taken up." The word "began" is important. If the Gospel was only the beginning, then Acts is not the story of what the apostles did but of what the risen Jesus keeps doing, now from heaven, by his Spirit, through his people.

The disciples' question in verse 6 reveals how slowly they understood. They had just spent forty days hearing about the kingdom from the risen Lord, and they still asked if he would restore Israel's national fortunes now. Jesus does not rebuke the hope. He reorders it. The kingdom will come, but the timeline belongs to the Father. In the meantime, they will receive power from the Holy Spirit and be witnesses in Jerusalem, Judea, Samaria, and to the end of the earth. This verse is the outline of the whole book of Acts. The kingdom advances not by political restoration but by the Spirit-empowered testimony of ordinary people.

Then Jesus rises. Luke writes it with restraint. There is no spectacle, no fireworks. He is lifted up, a cloud receives him, and the disciples keep staring at the sky. The cloud is not incidental. Throughout Scripture, a cloud is where God's glory dwells: the pillar in the wilderness, the cloud that filled the tabernacle, the cloud on the mount of transfiguration. Daniel 7:13 sees "one like a son of man" coming with the clouds of heaven to receive an everlasting dominion. The cloud tells the careful reader that Jesus is entering the glory of God, and that Daniel's vision has begun to come true.

The two men in white interrupt the staring. “Why do you stand looking into heaven?” It is a gentle rebuke, and it is also a promise. This same Jesus will come in the same way. The disciples do not need to scan the sky because they have a job to do and a future to expect.

Hebrews 4:14-16 tells us what Jesus is doing in the meantime. “We have a great high priest who has passed through the heavens.” The author is writing to weary believers who were tempted to drift back to the familiar comforts of the old covenant. His answer is to point them upward. The One who went up is a priest, which means he is on your behalf, now, before God. He is not a priest who stands aloof. Verse 15 says he can sympathize with our weaknesses, “one who in every respect has been tempted as we are, yet without sin.” He knows what it is to be tired, hungry, betrayed, and afraid. His ascended glory has not made him forget what it felt like.

Verse 16 is the invitation. “Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace.” Notice the combination of words: throne and grace. A throne suggests authority and judgment. Grace suggests undeserved favor. In the ascension, the two meet. The King who sits on the throne is the one who died for you. When you come before him, you do not find a stern judge reviewing your record but a priest who has already settled it. So you can come with confidence, which does not mean arrogance but boldness, and you will receive mercy for your past and grace for your needs.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 110 is the Old Testament backbone of this day. David writes, “The LORD says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool.” The New Testament quotes this verse more than any other Old Testament text, nearly always about the ascension. Daniel 7 provides the cloud and the Son of Man receiving dominion. Leviticus 16 provides the picture of the high priest entering the Most Holy Place with blood, which Hebrews says Christ has fulfilled. Looking forward, Acts 2 will show Peter explaining Pentecost as the work of the ascended Christ, and Revelation 5 will show the Lamb standing at the center of the throne.

STEP 6

Application

First, let the ascension settle where Jesus is. When life feels out of control, remember that someone is on the throne, and he is the one who loves you. Your circumstances do not outrank his authority.

Second, take your failures and weakness to him without delay. Hebrews says come with confidence. If you have been avoiding prayer because you feel unworthy, you have misunderstood the throne. It is a throne of grace. Tell him exactly what you are struggling with. He has been there.

Third, take comfort that Jesus is praying for you right now. Romans 8:34 says so. On days when you feel you cannot pray, the ascended Christ is already interceding.

Fourth, remember that you have been sent. The disciples were told to stop staring at the sky and start witnessing. Ask God this week to give you one specific opportunity to speak of Christ to someone, and then look for it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for ascending and sitting at the Father's right hand.

Thank him that he is your king and your high priest.

Ask him to give you confidence to come to his throne of grace.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 99

"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers."

ACTS 2:42

DAY 689 · WEEK 99

John 14:15-31; John 16:5-15; Acts 2:1-21

The Person and Work of the Holy Spirit

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 14:15-31, John 16:5-15, and Acts 2:1-21. Today is a doctrinal pause on the Holy Spirit: who he is and what he does. Notice what Jesus promised, and what happened at Pentecost.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

On the night before his death, Jesus promised his disciples another Helper. Fifty days after the resurrection, on the Jewish feast of Pentecost, that promise came true. The Spirit had been at work in the Old Testament, hovering over creation, empowering prophets and craftsmen, and anointing kings. But Pentecost marks the beginning of a new stage: the Spirit poured out on all God's people, as the new covenant promised. The church has confessed the Holy Spirit as the third person of the Trinity, equal with the Father and the Son.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Helper, to be with you forever, even the Spirit of truth" (John 14:16-17).
2. "But the Helper, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, he will teach you all things and bring to your remembrance all that I have said to you" (John 14:26).
3. "And when he comes, he will convict the world concerning sin and righteousness and judgment" (John 16:8).
4. "When the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth" (John 16:13).
5. "He will glorify me, for he will take what is mine and declare it to you" (John 16:14).

6. “And suddenly there came from heaven a sound like a mighty rushing wind, and it filled the entire house where they were sitting” (Acts 2:2).

7. “And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit gave them utterance” (Acts 2:4).

8. “And in the last days it shall be, God declares, that I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh” (Acts 2:17).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Holy Spirit is the third person of the Trinity: fully God, one in being with the Father and the Son, yet distinct as a person. Jesus calls him “he” and “the Helper” (the Greek word, paraclete, means one called alongside to help, advocate, or comfort). The Bible gives the Spirit divine attributes (eternal, all-knowing, present everywhere) and divine works (creation, inspiration of Scripture, new birth). His work in salvation is to apply what Christ has accomplished. He convicts of sin, gives new birth, unites believers to Christ, dwells within them, seals them, sanctifies them, gives gifts for the building up of the church, and assures them that they are God’s children. His ministry is Christ-centered: Jesus said, “He will glorify me.” At Pentecost, the Spirit was poured out on all believers, not just prophets and kings, as Joel foretold. Every Christian has the Spirit (Romans 8:9), and every Christian is called to be filled with him continually (Ephesians 5:18). Christians differ on the nature of some gifts, such as tongues and healing, and on whether the experience called the baptism or filling of the Spirit is distinct from conversion. All agree that without the Spirit there is no new life, no understanding of Scripture, and no power for witness.

STEP 4

Interpretation

In the Upper Room, Jesus tells his troubled disciples that he is leaving, but they will not be left as orphans. He will ask the Father, and the Father will give “another Helper.” The word “another” means another of the same kind. The Spirit will be to them what Jesus has been. And he will be with them forever. He is called the Spirit of truth. He will dwell with them and in them. He will teach them and remind them of what Jesus said. This is the promise behind the New Testament: the Spirit would help the apostles to remember and understand what Jesus taught, and so give us the Scriptures.

In chapter 16, Jesus says it is to their advantage that he goes away, for the Helper will not come otherwise. The Spirit’s work in the world is to convict: of sin, because they do not believe in Jesus; of righteousness, because Jesus goes to the Father and the world no longer

sees him; and of judgment, because the ruler of this world is judged. His work with believers is to guide them into all truth, and above all to glorify Christ. He does not speak on his own authority. A mark of the Spirit's presence is that Jesus is exalted.

Then on the day of Pentecost, the promise comes. A sound like a rushing wind fills the house. Tongues like flames rest on each of them. They are all filled with the Holy Spirit and speak in other languages, so that visitors from many nations each hear "the mighty works of God" in their own tongue. Some mock, saying they are drunk. Peter stands and quotes Joel: "In the last days, I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh, and your sons and daughters shall prophesy." The reversal of Babel has begun. At Babel languages were confused and people scattered. At Pentecost, languages are understood and people gathered. The Spirit comes on young and old, men and women, slave and free, so that the whole people of God can know him. This is the new covenant: not a few prophets but a kingdom of prophets.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:2 and Psalm 104:30 show the Spirit in creation. Numbers 11:29 has Moses wishing all the LORD's people were prophets. Ezekiel 36:26-27 and Jeremiah 31:33-34 promised the Spirit in the new covenant. Joel 2:28-32 is Peter's text. Genesis 11:1-9 is Babel. Romans 8:9-16 describes the Spirit in the believer. Ephesians 1:13-14 and 5:18 speak of the seal and the filling. Galatians 5:22-23 lists the fruit of the Spirit. 1 Corinthians 12 to 14 treat gifts.

STEP 6

Application

Thank the Father for the Spirit by name, and ask him to fill you today.

Notice where Jesus is being glorified in your life, a sign of the Spirit's work.

Ask the Spirit to open your Bible as you read, as Jesus promised.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank the Father for sending the Spirit to be with you forever.
- Ask the Spirit to teach you, convict you, and remind you of Jesus.
- Tell him where you need his help today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 99

“And they devoted themselves to the apostles’ teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers.”

ACTS 2:42

DAY 690 · WEEK 99

Acts 2:37-41; 2 Corinthians 7:8-11

Turning from sin to God

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Doctrine · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 2:37-41 and 2 Corinthians 7:8-11. Today is a doctrinal pause on repentance, turning from sin to God. Notice what Peter says after his sermon, and how Paul distinguishes two kinds of grief.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Peter has just preached the first Christian sermon, and the crowd has been told that they crucified the Messiah. Their question is the most important question: what shall we do? Peter's answer begins with repentance. In 2 Corinthians, Paul writes to a church he had grieved with a stern letter, and he rejoices at the result, not because they were hurt, but because the hurt led to repentance.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Now when they heard this they were cut to the heart, and said to Peter and the rest of the apostles, Brothers, what shall we do?" (Acts 2:37).
2. "Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit" (Acts 2:38).
3. "For the promise is for you and for your children and for all who are far off, everyone whom the Lord our God calls to himself" (Acts 2:39).
4. "So those who received his word were baptized, and there were added that day about three thousand souls" (Acts 2:41).
5. "As it is, I rejoice, not because you were grieved, but because you were grieved into repenting" (2 Corinthians 7:9).

6. “For godly grief produces a repentance that leads to salvation without regret” (2 Corinthians 7:10).
7. “Whereas worldly grief produces death” (2 Corinthians 7:10).
8. “For see what earnestness this godly grief has produced in you” (2 Corinthians 7:11).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Repentance is a change of mind and heart about sin and God that results in a change of direction. It includes three elements: recognizing sin for what it is, being sorry for it (not just for its consequences but because it offends God), and turning from it to God, with a purpose to obey. Repentance and faith are two sides of one turning: repentance turns from sin and faith turns to Christ. Jesus began his ministry by calling for both (Mark 1:15). Repentance is a gift of God (Acts 11:18, 2 Timothy 2:25), not a work that earns forgiveness, and it is a lifelong habit, not a one-time act. As Luther put it, the whole life of believers should be repentance. The Bible distinguishes godly grief from worldly grief. Worldly grief is sorrow over being caught or over the damage done to oneself. It can lead to bitterness or despair, as with Judas. Godly grief is sorrow over having sinned against God, and it moves us toward him. It leads to confession, change, and joy. Repentance does not bring forgiveness by its own merit. Forgiveness is on the basis of Christ’s death, received by faith. But there is no saving faith without repentance.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The crowd at Pentecost is “cut to the heart.” The Spirit has convicted them, as Jesus promised. They do not argue or defend themselves. They ask, “What shall we do?” Peter replies, “Repent and be baptized.” Repentance is first. It involves a change of mind about who Jesus is: the one they crucified is Lord and Christ. It involves a change of heart toward sin. Then comes baptism, the outward sign of entering the Christian community and being cleansed. The promise is the forgiveness of sins and the gift of the Holy Spirit. And the promise is for them, for their children, and for all who are far off, whom the Lord calls. Peter urges, “Save yourselves from this crooked generation.” About three thousand were added that day.

Paul’s letter to the Corinthians draws a vital distinction. Earlier he had sent a painful letter. He is glad, not because it hurt them, but because their pain led somewhere. “Godly grief produces a repentance that leads to salvation without regret, whereas worldly grief produces death.” Compare Peter, who wept bitterly and was restored, with Judas, who was remorseful but went away and hanged himself. Both felt sorrow. Peter’s sorrow brought him back to Christ. Judas’s sorrow turned inward and ended in despair.

Then Paul lists the fruit of true repentance: earnestness, eagerness to clear themselves, indignation, fear, longing, zeal, and a readiness to see justice done. Repentance is not just a feeling. It makes a difference in how we live. A genuinely repentant person wants to make things right.

For the new believer, repentance can feel frightening, as though God is looking for a reason to condemn. In fact, repentance is a gift. God leads us to it by his kindness (Romans 2:4). When you see your sin, it is the Spirit at work. And the way to the Father is always open: "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness" (1 John 1:9).

STEP 5

Connection

Mark 1:15 and Luke 24:47 call for repentance. Psalm 51 is David's great prayer of repentance. Joel 2:12-13 calls for returning to the LORD with the whole heart. Luke 15:17-24 is the prodigal's repentance. Matthew 26:75 and 27:3-5 contrast Peter and Judas. Romans 2:4 says God's kindness leads to repentance. 1 John 1:9 promises forgiveness. Revelation 2:5 calls churches to repent.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Psalm 51 slowly, and name any sin you need to turn from.

Ask yourself: is my grief over sin godly or worldly? Does it move me toward God or away?

Make a concrete change this week as the fruit of repentance, such as an apology, a restitution, or a broken habit.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the gift of repentance.
- Ask him to give you godly grief that leads to life.
- Confess a sin and turn from it, in your own words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 99

“And they devoted themselves to the apostles’ teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers.”

ACTS 2:42

DAY 691 · WEEK 99

Acts 2:42; Romans 10:14-17

The Means of Grace, Word, Sacrament, Prayer

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 2:42 and Romans 10:14-17. Today is a doctrinal pause on the means of grace: the ordinary ways God works in his people. Notice the four things the first church devoted itself to, and how Paul explains that faith comes by hearing.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After three thousand are added to the church at Pentecost, Luke gives a one-verse summary of what they did together. Paul, in Romans 10, explains why preaching is essential: no one can call on a Lord they have not heard about. The church has long called the means by which God gives and increases grace "the means of grace". The Reformers summarized them as the Word, the sacraments (baptism and the Lord's Supper), and prayer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And they devoted themselves to the apostles" teaching and the fellowship' (Acts 2:42).
2. "To the breaking of bread and the prayers" (Acts 2:42).
3. "For everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved" (Romans 10:13).
4. "How then will they call on him in whom they have not believed? And how are they to believe in him of whom they have never heard?" (Romans 10:14).
5. "And how are they to hear without someone preaching?" (Romans 10:14).
6. "And how are they to preach unless they are sent?" (Romans 10:15).
7. "How beautiful are the feet of those who preach the good news!" (Romans 10:15).
8. "So faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ" (Romans 10:17).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The means of grace are the ordinary channels through which God gives his people his blessing, strengthens their faith, and conforms them to Christ. They are not magic, and they do not work apart from faith and the Holy Spirit. But God has promised to use them. The Reformed tradition names three main means: the Word, the sacraments, and prayer. The Word, read and preached, is the primary means. “Faith comes from hearing” (Romans 10:17). The Spirit uses the Scriptures to convict, to convert, and to sanctify. The sacraments are the signs and seals of the gospel, instituted by Christ: baptism, which marks entrance into the covenant community, and the Lord’s Supper, in which believers feed on Christ by faith. Christians differ on how Christ is present in the Supper and on who should be baptized, but all agree that these are gifts to be received with faith. Prayer is the response to God’s Word and the believer’s way of seeking him. To these, Acts 2:42 adds fellowship, the life together in which believers encourage and build up one another. The means of grace are meant to be practiced in the context of a local church. They remind us that the Christian life is not a solo project. God gives grace through a people, a book, a meal, and a prayer.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Acts 2:42 is a short portrait of a healthy church. They “devoted themselves,” a word that means persistent, steadfast commitment. They did not drop in occasionally. First, “the apostles” teaching.’ The church was built on the teaching of those who had been with Jesus, now preserved in the New Testament. Second, “the fellowship,” the sharing of life, resources, and burdens that grows out of a shared faith. Third, “the breaking of bread,” which likely includes shared meals and the Lord’s Supper. Fourth, “the prayers,” both private and corporate.

Notice that these are ordinary things. There is no mention of a new program or a special technique. God works through ordinary means: teaching, fellowship, meals, and prayer. This is encouraging. You do not need extraordinary experiences to grow. You need to be steadily present in these four things.

Romans 10 makes the case for why the Word matters so much. Paul builds a chain of questions. People cannot call on the Lord unless they believe. They cannot believe unless they have heard. They cannot hear unless someone preaches. They cannot preach unless they are sent. So salvation depends on the proclamation of the gospel. “How beautiful are the feet of those who preach the good news!” Then the summary: “Faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ.” The word is not a mere pointer to something else. The Spirit works through it.

This is why time in the Word matters. You are putting yourself under the Word. It is also the reason that gathering with a church matters. You hear the Word preached, you pray with others, and you receive the sacraments. These are not extras. They are how God has chosen to feed his people.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 8:3 says man lives by every word from the mouth of God. Isaiah 55:10-11 says God's word accomplishes his purpose. Matthew 28:19-20 commands baptism and teaching. Luke 22:19 and 1 Corinthians 11:23-26 institute the Lord's Supper. Hebrews 10:24-25 calls us not to neglect meeting together. Colossians 3:16 says to let the word of Christ dwell richly. 1 Peter 2:2 says to long for the pure spiritual milk. Ephesians 4:11-16 describes the building up of the church.

STEP 6

Application

Evaluate your own pattern against the four: teaching, fellowship, bread, prayer. Which is weakest?

Commit to regular attendance at your church. Treat it as a means of grace, not an option.

Thank someone who first brought you the gospel. Their feet were beautiful.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the ordinary means of grace: his Word, the sacraments, and prayer.

Ask him to make you faithful in using them.

Ask him to meet you through them.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 99

"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers."

ACTS 2:42

DAY 692 · WEEK 99

Acts 2:1-47

Pentecost, the Spirit poured on all flesh

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 2:1-47. The Spirit falls on Pentecost, Peter preaches the first Christian sermon, three thousand repent, and the new community forms. You have already studied the Spirit and repentance in doctrinal pauses. Today, read the narrative as a whole.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Pentecost, fifty days after Passover, was one of three pilgrim feasts. Jerusalem was crowded with Jews from across the Roman world. The disciples were gathered together when the Spirit came. Peter's sermon is a model of apostolic preaching: it explains the event from the Scriptures, proclaims the death and resurrection of Jesus, and calls for repentance.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When the day of Pentecost arrived, they were all together in one place" (2:1).
2. "We hear them telling in our own tongues the mighty works of God" (2:11).
3. "And it shall come to pass that everyone who calls upon the name of the Lord shall be saved" (2:21).
4. "This Jesus, delivered up according to the definite plan and foreknowledge of God, you crucified and killed by the hands of lawless men" (2:23).
5. "Being therefore exalted at the right hand of God, and having received from the Father the promise of the Holy Spirit, he has poured out this that you yourselves are seeing and hearing" (2:33).
6. "Let all the house of Israel therefore know for certain that God has made him both Lord and Christ, this Jesus whom you crucified" (2:36).

7. “And all who believed were together and had all things in common” (2:44).
8. “Praising God and having favor with all the people. And the Lord added to their number day by day those who were being saved” (2:47).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Spirit comes on the disciples as promised. The visitors from many nations are amazed to hear the apostles speaking about the mighty works of God in their own languages. Some are perplexed, and others mock. Peter stands with the eleven and explains: this is what was spoken by the prophet Joel. In the last days, God will pour out his Spirit on all flesh. The day of the LORD has begun.

Peter then preaches Christ. Jesus of Nazareth was a man attested by God with mighty works, wonders, and signs. He was delivered up by the definite plan and foreknowledge of God, and killed by lawless men. Both are true: God’s plan and human guilt. But God raised him up, because it was not possible for death to hold him. Peter cites Psalm 16: David spoke of the resurrection of the Christ. David died and his tomb is here, but David was a prophet, and he spoke of one of his descendants. Peter then cites Psalm 110: “The Lord said to my Lord, Sit at my right hand.” Jesus is exalted, and from the right hand he has poured out the Spirit. “Let all the house of Israel therefore know for certain that God has made him both Lord and Christ.”

The result is conviction. Peter calls them to repent and be baptized, and about three thousand are added. Then Luke gives a picture of the new community. They devote themselves to the apostles’ teaching, fellowship, the breaking of bread, and prayer. Awe comes on every soul, and many wonders and signs are done by the apostles. They have all things in common, selling possessions to give to anyone in need. Day by day they attend the temple together and break bread in their homes with glad and generous hearts. They have favor with all the people, and the Lord adds to their number daily those who are being saved.

This is the birth of the church. It is not a human organization but a work of the Spirit, centered on the risen Christ. Its marks are Word, fellowship, sacrament, prayer, generosity, joy, and evangelism.

STEP 5

Connection

Joel 2:28-32 is the prophecy fulfilled. Psalm 16:8-11 and Psalm 110:1 are Peter’s texts. Leviticus 23:15-22 describes the Feast of Weeks. Exodus 19 and 20 recall the giving of the law at Sinai, as Pentecost came to be associated with it. Genesis 11 is Babel. Ezekiel 36:26-27 and Jeremiah 31:33 fit the new covenant. Romans 8:9 and Ephesians 2:19-22 describe the Spirit and the church. 1 John 3:17-18 teaches generosity.

STEP 6

Application

Read the sermon (2:14-41) aloud. Notice how Peter uses Scripture and then calls for a response.

Which of the marks of the early church would you like to see more in your own church? Pray for it.

Share something with someone in need this week, as the first believers did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for pouring out the Spirit on his people.

Tell him what it means that he is both Lord and Christ.

Ask him to fill you with his Spirit.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 99

"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers."

ACTS 2:42

DAY 693 · WEEK 99

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Acts 2:42 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers."

ACTS 2:42

REST

Meditation

Luke gives this single verse as a portrait of the first church after Pentecost. It is a pattern for every church that follows.

"They devoted themselves." The verb means to persist, to be strongly committed. It was not casual. These believers made time for each other and for the means of grace.

"To the apostles" teaching.' Their life was built on the teaching handed down from Jesus through his apostles. Today we have that teaching in the New Testament. A healthy church listens to Scripture.

"And the fellowship." The Greek word is koinonia, sharing in common. The church is a family, bound by the same Lord and the same Spirit, sharing life and burdens.

"The breaking of bread." This includes common meals and the Lord's Supper, where believers remember Jesus' death and feed on him by faith.

“And the prayers.” They prayed together, often and earnestly. The church began with prayer and moved forward in prayer.

When you wonder what the Christian life should look like, say this verse. It is simple, and it is enough to start.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began Acts with the risen Jesus’ promise: “You will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses.” Your first doctrinal pause was on Christ’s ascension, reigning and interceding. Then you studied the person of the Holy Spirit, and saw Jesus’ promise of a Helper fulfilled at Pentecost. A pause on repentance showed you the difference between godly grief and worldly grief. Another on the means of grace showed you the ordinary ways God feeds his people: Word, sacrament, prayer, and fellowship. In Acts 2 you read Peter’s first sermon, heard three thousand respond, and saw the birth of the church.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus ascended and now reigns at the Father’s right hand. How does knowing that he is on the throne and interceding for you change the way you face this week?

Peter’s hearers were cut to the heart and asked, “What shall we do?” When have you been cut to the heart by the Spirit? How did you respond?

Of the four things the first church devoted itself to (teaching, fellowship, breaking of bread, prayers), which do you most need to grow in?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for ascending and pouring out the Spirit.

Thank him for the church built at Pentecost.

Rest in him.

DAY 694 · WEEK 100

Acts 3:1-4:31

Healing at the gate; preaching; opposition begins

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 3:1-4:31. Peter and John heal a lame man at the temple gate, Peter preaches, and the apostles are arrested. They answer the council with bold words, and the church prays for boldness. Notice how Peter ties everything to Jesus' name.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Peter and John go up to the temple at the hour of prayer, three in the afternoon. At the Beautiful Gate, a man lame from birth is carried every day to beg. What follows is the first public miracle in Acts, and it leads to the first conflict with the authorities. The same leaders who condemned Jesus now face his disciples.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I have no silver and gold, but what I do have I give to you. In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, rise up and walk!" (3:6).
2. "And you killed the Author of life, whom God raised from the dead" (3:15).
3. "Repent therefore, and turn back, that your sins may be blotted out" (3:19).
4. "You are the sons of the prophets and of the covenant that God made with your fathers, saying to Abraham, And in your offspring shall all the families of the earth be blessed" (3:25).
5. "And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved" (4:12).
6. "Now when they saw the boldness of Peter and John, and perceived that they were uneducated, common men, they were astonished. And they recognized that they had

been with Jesus" (4:13).

7. "For we cannot but speak of what we have seen and heard" (4:20).

8. "And when they had prayed, the place in which they were gathered together was shaken, and they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and continued to speak the word of God with boldness" (4:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The lame man expects money. Peter says, "I have no silver and gold, but what I do have I give to you." What the church has is far greater: the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth. The man leaps up and enters the temple walking and leaping and praising God. The crowd gathers in amazement, and Peter preaches.

His sermon makes three points. First, don't look at us; the power is Jesus'. God has glorified his servant Jesus, whom you denied and killed, the Author of life, whom God raised. Second, you acted in ignorance, but God used it to fulfill what the prophets said about the Christ's suffering. Third, repent and turn back, that your sins may be blotted out, that times of refreshing may come from the Lord. And he reminds them that they are heirs of the covenant with Abraham: in your offspring all the families of the earth shall be blessed. God raised up his servant and sent him to you first, to bless you by turning every one of you from your wickedness. The Abrahamic promise is the framework for the mission.

The priests and the captain of the temple guard arrest them. But many who heard believed, and the number of men grew to about five thousand. The next day, before the same council that condemned Jesus, Peter, filled with the Holy Spirit, speaks of the rejected stone (Psalm 118): "There is salvation in no other name." This is a bold claim of Jesus' exclusivity. The council marvels at the confidence of "uneducated, common men" and recognizes that they had been with Jesus. With the healed man standing beside them, they have nothing to say. They warn them to stop speaking in this name. Peter and John answer: "Whether it is right in the sight of God to listen to you rather than to God, you must judge, for we cannot but speak of what we have seen and heard."

When released, they go to their friends, and the whole church prays. They do not ask for safety. They quote Psalm 2 (which you read in a few days) and pray for boldness. The place is shaken, and they are all filled with the Spirit and speak the word of God with boldness.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 52:13 and 53:11 speak of God's servant. Deuteronomy 18:15 is the prophet like Moses. Genesis 12:3 and 22:18 are the Abrahamic promise. Psalm 118:22 is the stone. Psalm 2:1-2 is quoted in Acts 4:25-26. Philippians 2:9-11 says God gave him the name above every name. John 14:6 says no one comes to the Father except through him. Hebrews 13:15 calls us to continually offer a sacrifice of praise.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you have to give that is better than silver and gold. Give it to someone this week.

When you are afraid to speak about Jesus, pray the church's prayer: not for safety, but for boldness.

Let people take note that you have been with Jesus. How?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that there is no other name by which we must be saved.

Ask him to make you bold.

Tell him what you would say to someone about him today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 100

"And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved."

ACTS 4:12

DAY 695 · WEEK 100

Acts 4:32-6:7

Sharing; Ananias and Sapphira; the Seven appointed

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 49 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 4:32-6:7. The church shares everything, Barnabas gives, Ananias and Sapphira lie to the Spirit, the apostles are arrested again, and seven men are chosen to serve. Notice the contrast between the true generosity and the false.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The young church is growing rapidly under pressure from outside and now faces problems from inside. In these chapters, we see its generosity, the danger of hypocrisy, further persecution, and an organizational crisis over the care of widows. In each, the church responds in a way that preserves its witness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Now the full number of those who believed were of one heart and soul, and no one said that any of the things that belonged to him was his own, but they had everything in common” (4:32).
2. “There was not a needy person among them” (4:34).
3. “Ananias, why has Satan filled your heart to lie to the Holy Spirit and to keep back for yourself part of the proceeds of the land?” (5:3).
4. “And great fear came upon the whole church and upon all who heard of these things” (5:11).
5. “We must obey God rather than men” (5:29).
6. “Then they left the presence of the council, rejoicing that they were counted worthy to suffer dishonor for the name” (5:41).

7 “Therefore, brothers, pick out from among you seven men of good repute, full of the Spirit and of wisdom, whom we will appoint to this duty” (6:3).

8 “And the word of God continued to increase, and the number of the disciples multiplied greatly in Jerusalem” (6:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The church was of one heart and soul. The believers sold property and laid the proceeds at the apostles’ feet to be distributed to those in need. This was voluntary, not compulsory, and a spontaneous overflow of love. Barnabas, whose name means “son of encouragement,” sold a field and gave the money.

Ananias and Sapphira did the same, but they kept back part and pretended to give all. Peter says, “You have not lied to man but to God.” Both fall dead. The sin was not keeping part of the money. Peter says the land was theirs to keep. The sin was hypocrisy: pretending to be more generous than they were, to gain a reputation. Luke says great fear came on the whole church. God takes the purity of his church seriously.

The apostles continue to do signs, and the sick are brought into the streets. The high priest and the Sadducees are filled with jealousy and arrest them, but an angel opens the prison doors at night and tells them to go and preach. When they are brought before the council, they say: “We must obey God rather than men.” Peter again preaches Jesus, crucified and raised, to give repentance and forgiveness. The council wants to kill them, but Gamaliel, a respected teacher of the law, advises caution: if this is from men, it will fail; if it is from God, you cannot overthrow it. They flog the apostles and charge them not to speak in Jesus’ name. The apostles leave “rejoicing that they were counted worthy to suffer dishonor for the name.”

Then comes an internal problem. The Greek-speaking widows are being overlooked in the daily distribution. The apostles do not dismiss the complaint. They gather the disciples and propose that seven men be chosen to oversee this ministry, so that the apostles can devote themselves to prayer and the ministry of the word. The seven all have Greek names, suggesting they were from the complaining group. The church chooses them, the apostles pray and lay hands on them, “and the word of God continued to increase.” Stephen and Philip are among them. The church solves a problem by creating a ministry of service, a model for the later office of deacon.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 15:4 said there should be no poor among you if you obey. Joshua 7 is the story of Achan's hidden sin, with a similar severity. Proverbs 21:3 says to do righteousness and justice. Matthew 6:1-4 warns against giving to be seen. Galatians 6:2 says to bear one another's burdens. 1 Timothy 3:8-13 describes deacons. James 1:27 speaks of caring for widows. 2 Corinthians 9:7 says God loves a cheerful giver.

STEP 6

Application

Examine your own giving. Is it done for God or for a reputation? Give something in secret.

Pray for your church's leaders, that they would devote themselves to prayer and the Word.

Where is someone being overlooked in your church? What could you do?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the generosity of the early church.
- Ask him to keep you from hypocrisy.
- Ask him to teach you to give from a sincere heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 100

"And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved."

ACTS 4:12

DAY 696 · WEEK 100

Psalm 2

The nations rage, Peter's Pentecost proclamation

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 2. The nations plot against the LORD and his Anointed, but the LORD installs his King. You met this psalm earlier in the plan; today read it through Acts 4, where the church prays it after the first arrests.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 2 was a coronation psalm, sung when a king of David's line took the throne. In the New Testament it is quoted as speaking of Jesus, the ultimate Anointed One. In Acts 4:25-26, the believers quote verses 1 and 2 as they pray after the arrest of Peter and John. They see Herod, Pilate, the nations, and the peoples of Israel as the fulfillment of the rage. Their confidence is that the one enthroned in heaven laughs.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain?" (v. 1).
2. "The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the LORD and against his Anointed" (v. 2).
3. "He who sits in the heavens laughs; the Lord holds them in derision" (v. 4).
4. "As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill" (v. 6).
5. "I will tell of the decree: The LORD said to me, You are my Son; today I have begotten you" (v. 7).
6. "Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage, and the ends of the earth your possession" (v. 8).
7. "Now therefore, O kings, be wise; be warned, O rulers of the earth" (v. 10).

8 “Kiss the Son, lest he be angry, and you perish in the way, for his wrath is quickly kindled. Blessed are all who take refuge in him” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a question that has echoed through history: “Why do the nations rage?” Power rises against God. The kings of the earth take counsel together against the LORD and his Anointed, saying, “Let us burst their bonds apart and cast away their cords from us.” They want to be free of God’s rule.

The answer from heaven is surprising: “He who sits in the heavens laughs.” It is not a laugh of amusement but of contempt for the futility of the plan. The nations are not a threat to God. Then he speaks in his wrath: “As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill.” The decision is made. The King is installed.

Then the King himself speaks: “I will tell of the decree: The LORD said to me, You are my Son; today I have begotten you.” In the Davidic covenant, the king was adopted as God’s son (2 Samuel 7:14). The New Testament sees the full meaning in Jesus. The Father said this at his baptism and the Transfiguration, and Paul says that Jesus was declared to be the Son of God in power by his resurrection (Romans 1:4, Acts 13:33). The Son is promised the nations as his heritage and the ends of the earth as his possession. This is the Great Commission in the language of the Psalms. The nations belong to Christ, and the mission of Acts is the fulfillment. He will rule with an iron rod. The nations that do not submit will be broken.

The psalm ends with a call to the kings to be wise: “Serve the LORD with fear, and rejoice with trembling. Kiss the Son.” To kiss the Son is to pay homage, to submit. “Lest he be angry, and you perish in the way.” And the final line is a gospel invitation: “Blessed are all who take refuge in him.” The Son who will judge is also the refuge. The first psalm opened with “Blessed is the man,” and the second ends with “Blessed are all who take refuge in him.”

In Acts, the church faces the rage of the rulers. They pray this psalm, and the place is shaken. The King is on the throne, and their courage comes from knowing it.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Samuel 7:12-16 is the Davidic covenant behind the psalm. Psalm 89:26-27 repeats the sonship. Acts 4:25-28 and 13:33 quote Psalm 2. Hebrews 1:5 and 5:5 apply it to Christ. Matthew 3:17 and 17:5 echo verse 7. Revelation 2:26-27, 12:5, and 19:15 use the iron rod. Romans 1:4 says he was declared the Son of God by the resurrection. Philippians 2:9-11 describes the whole earth bowing.

STEP 6

Application

When the news makes you anxious about rulers and nations, read verse 4 and remember who sits in the heavens.

Submit an area of your life that you have kept back from Christ's rule. Kiss the Son.

Take refuge in him today, by name, in prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what rage and plotting you see around you.

Thank him for the King he has set on Zion.

Take refuge in the Son.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 100

"And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved."

ACTS 4:12

DAY 697 · WEEK 100

Psalm 16

You will not abandon my soul to Sheol

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 16. David's confidence in the LORD reaches past death. Both Peter in Acts 2 and Paul in Acts 13 quote verse 10 as a prophecy of the resurrection of Jesus.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 16 is a "miktam" of David, a poem of trust. David asks for protection and then declares that the LORD is his chosen portion. The mood is quiet and joyful confidence. The psalm ends with a hope that goes beyond what David himself experienced, which is why Peter says David "foresaw and spoke about the resurrection of the Christ."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Preserve me, O God, for in you I take refuge" (v. 1).
2. "I say to the LORD, You are my Lord; I have no good apart from you" (v. 2).
3. "The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot" (v. 5).
4. "The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance" (v. 6).
5. "I bless the LORD who gives me counsel; in the night also my heart instructs me" (v. 7).
6. "I have set the LORD always before me; because he is at my right hand, I shall not be shaken" (v. 8).
7. "For you will not abandon my soul to Sheol, or let your holy one see corruption" (v. 10).
8. "You make known to me the path of life; in your presence there is fullness of joy; at your right hand are pleasures forevermore" (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David begins by taking refuge: “Preserve me, O God, for in you I take refuge.” He affirms that the LORD is his Lord and that he has no good apart from him. All his delight is in the saints in the land, the people of God. Those who run after other gods multiply their sorrows.

Then the heart of the psalm: “The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot.” In Israel, each tribe received a portion of land, except Levi, whose portion was the LORD himself. David applies this to himself. The LORD is his inheritance. The boundary lines have fallen in pleasant places. Having God, he has everything.

He blesses the LORD for counsel, even at night, and sets the LORD always before him. Because God is at his right hand, he will not be shaken. “Therefore my heart is glad, and my whole being rejoices; my flesh also dwells secure.”

Then comes verse 10: “For you will not abandon my soul to Sheol, or let your holy one see corruption.” In David’s own situation, this is a confident hope of rescue from death. But Peter says on Pentecost that David died and was buried, and his tomb is with us to this day. David was a prophet and knew God had sworn to set one of his descendants on his throne. “He foresaw and spoke about the resurrection of the Christ, that he was not abandoned to Hades, nor did his flesh see corruption.” The ultimate holy one is Jesus, whom God raised up. Paul argues in Acts 13:35-37 the same way.

The psalm ends with the path of life: “in your presence there is fullness of joy; at your right hand are pleasures forevermore.” This is the believer’s hope too. Because Christ rose, we too will be raised. The presence of God is not just a duty but a joy that never ends.

STEP 5

Connection

Numbers 18:20 and Deuteronomy 10:9 say the LORD is the Levites’ inheritance. Psalm 73:25-26 also says God is my portion. Psalm 17:15 expresses the hope of beholding God. Acts 2:25-32 and 13:35-37 quote and explain verse 10. 1 Corinthians 15:20-23 says Christ is the firstfruits of the resurrection. Hebrews 12:2 says Jesus endured the cross for the joy set before him. Matthew 5:8 promises that the pure in heart will see God.

STEP 6

Application

Say “You are my Lord; I have no good apart from you” as a prayer. What other goods compete for your heart?

Thank God for the beautiful inheritance of being his child.

Meditate on verse 11. What would it mean to live today in the path of life?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God that you have no good apart from him.

Thank him for the beautiful inheritance he has given you.

Thank him that he will not abandon your soul.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 100

"And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved."

ACTS 4:12

DAY 698 · WEEK 100

Psalm 110:1-7

Sit at my right hand, the exalted Christ

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 110:1-7. This is the psalm quoted more than any other in the New Testament. Peter uses it on Pentecost to prove that Jesus is exalted at God's right hand. You first met it in the Old Testament. Read it now as the psalm of the ascension.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 110 is a psalm of David about a figure he calls "my Lord." The psalm describes a king-priest, seated at God's right hand, who will rule over his enemies. David himself was not a priest, and no king of Israel was both king and priest. Jesus asked the Pharisees how the Christ could be David's son when David called him Lord (Mark 12:35-37). The answer in Acts is that Jesus, risen and ascended, is the one to whom David spoke.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD sends forth from Zion your mighty scepter. Rule in the midst of your enemies!" (v. 2).
3. "Your people will offer themselves freely on the day of your power" (v. 3).
4. "The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind" (v. 4).
5. "You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek" (v. 4).
6. "The Lord is at your right hand; he will shatter kings on the day of his wrath" (v. 5).
7. "He will execute judgment among the nations" (v. 6).
8. "He will drink from the brook by the way; therefore he will lift up his head" (v. 7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a conversation in heaven: “The LORD says to my Lord.” The first LORD is Yahweh, and the second is David’s Lord, the Messiah. The Messiah is invited to sit at God’s right hand, the place of honor and authority, until all his enemies are made his footstool. In Acts 2:34-35, Peter says that David did not ascend into the heavens, but he said, “The Lord said to my Lord, Sit at my right hand.” Jesus is the Lord to whom David referred. The ascension is the fulfillment of this verse.

The King’s rule extends from Zion. The mighty scepter is sent forth, and he rules in the midst of his enemies. This describes the current age: the King reigns now, though his enemies have not yet been put under his feet. His people willingly offer themselves, “in holy garments,” like an army of volunteers on the day of his power. This describes the church.

Then comes the astonishing oath in verse 4: “You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek.” Melchizedek in Genesis 14 was both king of Salem and priest of God Most High, who blessed Abraham. In Israel, kings came from Judah and priests from Levi. This verse promises a priest-king who is outside the Levitical order and whose priesthood is eternal. The book of Hebrews makes this central: Jesus is our great high priest, not by descent from Aaron, but by the oath of God, living forever to intercede for us (Hebrews 5 to 7). The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind. His priesthood is as secure as God’s word.

The last stanza describes the judgment: he will shatter kings on the day of his wrath, execute judgment among the nations, and shatter chiefs over the wide earth. He drinks from the brook by the way and lifts up his head, a picture of a victorious warrior refreshed in the pursuit. The psalm combines the two offices that Acts presents: Jesus as king ruling from heaven and as priest interceding for his people. And the victory is certain.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 14:18-20 is Melchizedek. Hebrews 1:13, 5:6, 7:1-28, 8:1, and 10:12-13 apply the psalm to Christ. Matthew 22:41-46 records Jesus asking about David’s Lord. Acts 2:34-36 uses verse 1. Ephesians 1:20-22 says God seated Christ at his right hand. 1 Corinthians 15:25 says he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. Romans 8:34 says Christ is at the right hand of God, interceding for us. Zechariah 6:12-13 describes a priest on his throne.

STEP 6

Application

Remember that Jesus is both king and priest. Bring a need to him as King, and a failure to him as Priest.

Thank him for living forever to intercede for you.

Pray “until I make your enemies your footstool” over a difficult area of the world, and wait for him to act.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship Jesus at the Father’s right hand.
- Thank him for being a priest forever.
- Ask him to rule over your enemies, inside and out.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 100

“And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved.”

ACTS 4:12

DAY 699 · WEEK 100

Acts 6:8-8:3

Stephen's sermon and martyrdom; Saul appears

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 6:8-8:3. Stephen, one of the seven, is full of grace and power. He is arrested, gives a long speech to the council, and is stoned. A young man named Saul is introduced. Read Stephen's last words slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Stephen, who was chosen to serve tables, also does signs and speaks with wisdom. Members of a synagogue argue with him and cannot withstand the Spirit by whom he spoke. They bring false witnesses who say he spoke against the temple and the law. His speech summarizes Israel's history from Abraham to Solomon and ends with an accusation. His death begins a persecution that scatters the church and sets the stage for the gospel's spread.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And Stephen, full of grace and power, was doing great wonders and signs among the people" (6:8).
2. "And gazing at him, all who sat in the council saw that his face was like the face of an angel" (6:15).
3. "The God of glory appeared to our father Abraham when he was in Mesopotamia" (7:2).
4. "You stiff-necked people, uncircumcised in heart and ears, you always resist the Holy Spirit" (7:51).
5. "But he, full of the Holy Spirit, gazed into heaven and saw the glory of God, and Jesus standing at the right hand of God" (7:55).
6. "Lord Jesus, receive my spirit" (7:59).

7. “Lord, do not hold this sin against them” (7:60).
8. “And there arose on that day a great persecution against the church in Jerusalem” (8:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Stephen is accused of speaking blasphemous words against Moses and God. He is brought before the council, and his face looks like an angel’s. When the high priest asks if these things are so, Stephen gives a long speech. It is not a defense but a sermon, retelling the history of Israel. His point is that God has never been confined to one place. The God of glory appeared to Abraham in Mesopotamia, before there was a land or a temple. He was with Joseph in Egypt, with Moses in Midian and at Sinai. The tabernacle was a tent that moved, and Solomon built the temple, “yet the Most High does not dwell in houses made by hands.” At each stage, Israel resisted: Joseph’s brothers sold him, Israel rejected Moses, and they made a golden calf.

Then he turns the history on his hearers. “You stiff-necked people, uncircumcised in heart and ears, you always resist the Holy Spirit. As your fathers did, so do you. Which of the prophets did your fathers not persecute? They killed those who announced beforehand the coming of the Righteous One, whom you have now betrayed and murdered.” They are enraged.

Stephen, full of the Holy Spirit, looks into heaven and sees the glory of God and Jesus standing at the right hand of God. Everywhere else in the New Testament, Jesus is seated at the Father’s right hand. Here he stands, as if rising to receive his first martyr or to testify on his behalf. The crowd covers their ears, rushes him, drags him out of the city, and stones him. The witnesses lay their garments at the feet of a young man named Saul.

Stephen’s death echoes Jesus’ death. He prays, “Lord Jesus, receive my spirit,” and “Lord, do not hold this sin against them.” He kneels and dies, and Luke says he “fell asleep.” Saul approved of his execution. A great persecution arises, and the church is scattered throughout Judea and Samaria, except the apostles. Saul ravages the church, entering house after house. But as Jesus said in Acts 1:8, the gospel is about to move beyond Jerusalem. The scattering of the church is the way the word of God spreads.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 12 to 50, Exodus, and 1 Kings 6 and 8 are the history Stephen retells. Isaiah 66:1-2 is quoted in the speech. Jeremiah 7:1-15 warned about trusting in the temple. Deuteronomy 10:16 and Jeremiah 9:26 speak of uncircumcised hearts. Luke 23:34 and 23:46 are Jesus’

similar prayers. Matthew 5:10-12 blesses the persecuted. Philippians 1:29 says we are given the privilege of suffering for his sake. Acts 22:20 has Paul recalling Stephen's death.

STEP 6

Application

Notice how Stephen was able to forgive. Pray for someone who has harmed you.

Ask what "houses made by hands" you trust in: a building, a tradition, a routine? Remember that God goes with his people.

Pray for Christians who are persecuted today by name if you know them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to fill you with the Holy Spirit.
- Ask him for courage, like Stephen's, to look to heaven.
- Pray for those who oppose you, as Stephen did.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 100

"And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved."

ACTS 4:12

DAY 700 · WEEK 100

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Acts 4:12 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved."

ACTS 4:12

REST

Meditation

Peter says this to the Jewish council that condemned Jesus. Hours earlier, he had been arrested, and now he stands before the same rulers, filled with the Holy Spirit.

"And there is salvation in no one else." This is a bold and exclusive claim. Peter does not say Jesus is one of many ways. He says salvation is found in him alone. This was not popular in the first century, and it is not popular now. But it is the heart of the gospel.

"For there is no other name under heaven." The name stands for the person, his authority and character. There is no other person anywhere who can do what Jesus does.

"Given among men." Salvation is a gift. God gave this name. We did not discover it by our efforts.

"By which we must be saved." The word "must" shows the necessity. We need saving. We cannot save ourselves. And there is a name by which we can be saved.

This verse is a comfort and a commission. It comforts because the way to God is open in Jesus. It commissions because if there is no other name, then people need to hear it.

When you are tempted to doubt that Jesus is enough, or when you are unsure about speaking of him, say this verse.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read Peter's healing at the Beautiful Gate, his bold preaching, and his words to the council: "There is salvation in no other name." You saw the early church share its possessions, and you saw the hypocrisy of Ananias and Sapphira. You watched seven men be chosen to serve. Three psalms about the exalted Christ framed Peter's sermons: Psalm 2, in which the LORD sets his King on Zion and the nations rage in vain; Psalm 16, in which God does not abandon his holy one to Sheol; and Psalm 110, in which the Lord sits at God's right hand as priest and king. Finally, you saw Stephen preach to the council, see Jesus standing in heaven, and forgive his murderers as he died. A young man named Saul stood by. A great persecution scattered the church.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Peter and John said, "We cannot but speak of what we have seen and heard." What have you seen and heard of Jesus that you cannot keep to yourself?

Stephen forgave those who killed him, as Jesus did. Who is one person you need to forgive, and what would it take to pray for them?

The psalms of the week show Christ reigning at God's right hand. How does knowing that he is on the throne give you courage in the thing you fear most?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that there is salvation in no other name, and that you have found it.

Ask him for the boldness of Peter.

Rest in him.

DAY 701 · WEEK 101

Acts 8:4-40

Philip; the Samaritans; Simon the magician; the Ethiopian

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 37 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 8:4-40. Persecution scatters the believers and Philip takes the gospel to Samaria and then to an Ethiopian official. Notice how the gospel crosses ethnic and social lines, and how Philip uses Isaiah 53.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The persecution that began with Stephen scatters the church, and wherever they go, they preach. Philip, one of the seven, goes to Samaria, a region of mixed descent despised by Jews. This fulfills the second step of Acts 1:8. Then an angel sends him on a desert road, where he meets an Ethiopian court official, the first African convert recorded in Acts.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Now those who were scattered went about preaching the word” (8:4).
2. “Philip went down to the city of Samaria and proclaimed to them the Christ” (8:5).
3. “Then they laid their hands on them and they received the Holy Spirit” (8:17).
4. “May your silver perish with you, because you thought you could obtain the gift of God with money!” (8:20).
5. “So Philip ran to him and heard him reading Isaiah the prophet and asked, Do you understand what you are reading?” (8:30).
6. “Then Philip opened his mouth, and beginning with this Scripture he told him the good news about Jesus” (8:35).
7. “And when they came up out of the water, the Spirit of the Lord carried Philip away, and the eunuch saw him no more, and went on his way rejoicing” (8:39).

8 “So there was much joy in that city” (8:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Persecution scatters the church, but the believers go about preaching the word. What the enemy meant for harm, God used to spread the gospel. Philip goes to Samaria and proclaims Christ. The crowds pay attention as they see signs: unclean spirits come out, and the paralyzed and lame are healed. “So there was much joy in that city.” The long hostility between Jews and Samaritans begins to heal in Christ.

A man named Simon had amazed the Samaritans with magic, claiming to be someone great. He believes and is baptized, but later, when he sees the Spirit given through the laying on of hands by Peter and John, he offers money for the power. Peter replies sharply: “Your heart is not right before God. Repent.” Christians differ on whether Simon’s faith was genuine. The main lesson is that the gift of God cannot be bought, and the heart must be right.

The apostles Peter and John come from Jerusalem to the Samaritans, who had been baptized but had not yet received the Spirit. When they lay hands on them, the Spirit comes. This is an unusual sequence, and interpreters explain it as a special moment as the gospel crossed a boundary: the Samaritans received the Spirit in the presence of the apostles, so that the Jerusalem church would recognize them as full members. It is not the usual pattern, where the Spirit comes with faith (Romans 8:9).

An angel directs Philip to a desert road. He meets an Ethiopian court official, treasurer of the queen, who has been to Jerusalem to worship and is returning in his chariot, reading Isaiah 53. Philip asks, “Do you understand what you are reading?” “How can I, unless someone guides me?” The passage is the suffering servant, led like a sheep to the slaughter. “About whom does the prophet say this?” Philip begins with this Scripture and tells him the good news about Jesus. The man asks to be baptized in some water they pass. After the baptism, the Spirit takes Philip away, and the eunuch goes on his way rejoicing. Tradition holds that he carried the gospel to Africa.

The gospel is moving. It reached Samaritans, who were half-Jewish, and now an African who was excluded from the temple assembly under the law (Deuteronomy 23:1) but who is welcomed in Christ, as Isaiah 56:3-5 promised.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 53:7-8 is the passage the Ethiopian was reading. Isaiah 56:3-5 promises a place for eunuchs in God’s house. Psalm 68:31 says Cush will stretch out its hands to God. John 4:1-42 shows Jesus ministering in Samaria. Luke 9:51-56 shows earlier Samaritan hostility. 1 Peter

1:10-12 says the prophets searched for the sufferings of Christ. Luke 24:27 and 24:45 show Jesus opening the Scriptures. Romans 10:14-15 says how can they hear without someone preaching.

STEP 6

Application

Ask a friend about what they are reading, and be ready like Philip to explain from Scripture.

Notice whom your culture excludes. How could you bring the gospel to them?

Thank God that persecution cannot stop his word.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for using hard things to spread his word.
- Ask him to make you willing to go where he sends.
- Ask him to open your eyes to someone who is seeking.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 101

"To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

ACTS 10:43

DAY 702 · WEEK 101

Acts 9:1-43

Saul's conversion; Peter's miracles

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 9:1-43. Saul meets the risen Christ on the Damascus road, is converted, and begins to preach. Peter heals Aeneas and raises Tabitha. Notice how Jesus identifies himself with his people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Saul of Tarsus, a Pharisee trained under Gamaliel, was the leading persecutor of the church. He obtained letters from the high priest to arrest believers in Damascus. This is the pivotal conversion in Acts. Luke tells it here, and Paul tells it again in chapters 22 and 26. It changed the history of the church. The persecutor became the apostle to the Gentiles.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But Saul, still breathing threats and murder against the disciples of the Lord, went to the high priest" (9:1).
2. "Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me?" (9:4).
3. "Who are you, Lord? And he said, I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting" (9:5).
4. "Go, for he is a chosen instrument of mine to carry my name before the Gentiles and kings and the children of Israel" (9:15).
5. "For I will show him how much he must suffer for the sake of my name" (9:16).
6. "And immediately he proclaimed Jesus in the synagogues, saying, He is the Son of God" (9:20).
7. "So the church throughout all Judea and Galilee and Samaria had peace and was being built up" (9:31).

8 “Tabitha, arise” (9:40).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Saul is on the road to Damascus when a light from heaven flashes around him. He falls to the ground and hears a voice: “Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me?” Notice that Jesus says “me.” To persecute the church is to persecute Christ. The church is united to him as a body to its head. “Who are you, Lord?” “I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting.” Saul has been convinced that Jesus was a blasphemer who died under God’s curse. Now he meets him, glorified.

Saul is blind and led by the hand into Damascus. For three days he neither eats nor drinks. A disciple named Ananias is told in a vision to go to him. Ananias protests: this man has done great harm to your saints. But the Lord says, “Go, for he is a chosen instrument of mine to carry my name before the Gentiles and kings and the children of Israel. For I will show him how much he must suffer for the sake of my name.” Ananias goes, lays hands on him, and calls him “Brother Saul.” Something like scales fall from his eyes, and he is baptized.

His conversion is the work of sovereign grace. He was not seeking Christ. He was breathing threats. Jesus found him. And his call was clear from the start: to carry Christ’s name to the Gentiles. Immediately he proclaims Jesus in the synagogues: “He is the Son of God.” The people are amazed. “Is this not the man who made havoc in Jerusalem?” He baffles the Jews by proving that Jesus is the Christ. The Jews plot to kill him, and the disciples let him down over the wall in a basket.

In Jerusalem, the disciples are afraid of him, but Barnabas takes him and brings him to the apostles. Barnabas, the encourager, is vital here. Luke notes that the church throughout Judea, Galilee, and Samaria had peace, was built up, and multiplied.

Peter heals Aeneas, a paralytic in Lydda, and raises Tabitha (Dorcas), a woman known for good works, in Joppa. Many believe. Peter stays in Joppa with Simon, a tanner, a detail that prepares for the next chapter, because tanners were ceremonially unclean.

STEP 5

Connection

Galatians 1:11-24 is Paul’s own account of his conversion. Philippians 3:4-11 tells how he counted all things as loss. 1 Timothy 1:12-16 says Christ came to save sinners, of whom Paul is the foremost. Ephesians 5:30 says we are members of his body. Matthew 25:40 and 25:45 speak of what is done to the least of these. 2 Corinthians 11:23-33 recounts his sufferings, including the basket. Romans 15:15-21 shows his Gentile mission.

STEP 6

Application

Remember your own conversion, however quiet. Write down how Christ found you.

Be an Ananias to someone who seems beyond reach. Is there someone you've written off?

Be a Barnabas: look for someone to encourage and bring into the fellowship.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for finding you, like Saul on the road.

Thank him for being one with his people.

Ask him to use you as he used Saul.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 101

"To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

ACTS 10:43

DAY 703 · WEEK 101

Acts 10:1-11:30

Cornelius, the Gentiles receive the Spirit

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 78 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 10:1-11:30. God sends Peter to the household of Cornelius, a Roman centurion, and the Holy Spirit falls on Gentiles. Peter defends this in Jerusalem, and the church at Antioch is born. This is the hinge of Acts.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Cornelius, a centurion in Caesarea, is a God-fearer who prays and gives alms. Peter is in Joppa, hungry, praying on a rooftop. God arranges both visions to bring them together. For a Jew to enter a Gentile house was against custom, and it was a major step. The conversion of Cornelius opens the door for Gentiles to enter the church without becoming Jews first.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "A devout man who feared God with all his household, gave alms generously to the people, and prayed continually to God" (10:2).
2. "What God has made clean, do not call common" (10:15).
3. "Truly I understand that God shows no partiality, but in every nation anyone who fears him and does what is right is acceptable to him" (10:34).
4. "To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name" (10:43).
5. "While Peter was still saying these things, the Holy Spirit fell on all who heard the word" (10:44).
6. "Then to the Gentiles also God has granted repentance that leads to life" (11:18).

7. “When he came and saw the grace of God, he was glad, and he exhorted them all to remain faithful to the Lord with steadfast purpose” (11:23).

8. “And in Antioch the disciples were first called Christians” (11:26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter has a vision of a sheet lowered from heaven filled with animals, clean and unclean. A voice says, “Rise, Peter; kill and eat.” Peter objects: “I have never eaten anything that is common or unclean.” The voice replies, “What God has made clean, do not call common.” This happens three times. While Peter wonders about the vision, the men from Cornelius arrive. The Spirit tells Peter to go with them. He realizes that the vision was not just about food but about people. “God has shown me that I should not call any person common or unclean.”

At Cornelius’s house, a crowd has gathered. Peter says, “Truly I understand that God shows no partiality, but in every nation anyone who fears him and does what is right is acceptable to him.” He then preaches the gospel: Jesus of Nazareth, anointed with the Holy Spirit and with power, went about doing good, was killed by hanging on a tree, and raised on the third day. “To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name.” Notice: forgiveness is received through faith in him. While Peter is still speaking, the Holy Spirit falls on all who hear. The Jewish believers with Peter are amazed that the gift of the Holy Spirit has been poured out on Gentiles, for they hear them speaking in tongues and extolling God. Peter asks, “Can anyone withhold water for baptizing these people who have received the Holy Spirit just as we have?” They are baptized.

When Peter returns to Jerusalem, believers criticize him: “You went to uncircumcised men and ate with them.” Peter explains step by step. “If then God gave the same gift to them as he gave to us when we believed in the Lord Jesus Christ, who was I that I could stand in God’s way?” They fall silent and glorify God: “Then to the Gentiles also God has granted repentance that leads to life.”

Meanwhile, those scattered after Stephen’s death have reached Antioch, where some preached to Greeks as well, and many believed. The Jerusalem church sends Barnabas, who sees the grace of God and rejoices, then fetches Saul. For a year they teach a great company, “and in Antioch the disciples were first called Christians.” The church in Antioch will become the base for the first missionary journey.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 11 is the food laws. Genesis 12:3 promised blessing to all nations through Abraham. Isaiah 49:6 is the light to the Gentiles. Deuteronomy 10:17 says God is not partial. Ephesians 2:11-22 describes the Gentiles made near. Galatians 2:11-14 shows Peter struggling again with table fellowship. Romans 2:11 and 3:29-30 say God is the God of Gentiles as well. Mark 7:19 says Jesus declared all foods clean.

STEP 6

Application

Ask who you have been treating as “common or unclean,” and ask God to change your view.

Invite someone from a different background to share a meal with you this week.

Remember that you are among the Gentiles to whom God granted repentance that leads to life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he shows no partiality.

Thank him for sending the gospel to you.

Ask him to forgive where you have shown partiality.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 101

“To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name.”

ACTS 10:43

DAY 704 · WEEK 101

Acts 12:1-13:52

Peter freed; the first missionary journey begins

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 77 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 12:1-13:52. James is killed, Peter is freed from prison, Herod dies, and the Holy Spirit sends out Barnabas and Saul on the first missionary journey. Paul preaches in Pisidian Antioch. Notice the role of prayer and the Spirit in every stage.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Persecution intensifies under King Herod Agrippa I. He kills James the brother of John and arrests Peter. Then the scene moves to Antioch, where the church worships and fasts. What follows is a new stage in Acts: the church deliberately sends missionaries to the Gentile world. From here on, the focus shifts from Peter to Paul, and the geography widens.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "So Peter was kept in prison, but earnest prayer for him was made to God by the church" (12:5).
2. "And the angel struck Peter on the side and woke him, saying, Get up quickly" (12:7).
3. "But the word of God increased and multiplied" (12:24).
4. "While they were worshiping the Lord and fasting, the Holy Spirit said, Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them" (13:2).
5. "And by him everyone who believes is freed from everything from which you could not be freed by the law of Moses" (13:39).
6. "For so the Lord has commanded us, saying, I have made you a light for the Gentiles, that you may bring salvation to the ends of the earth" (13:47).

7. “And when the Gentiles heard this, they began rejoicing and glorifying the word of the Lord, and as many as were appointed to eternal life believed” (13:48).

8. “And the disciples were filled with joy and with the Holy Spirit” (13:52).

STEP 4

Interpretation

James is executed with the sword, and Herod, seeing that it pleases the Jews, arrests Peter. He plans to bring him out after Passover. “So Peter was kept in prison, but earnest prayer for him was made to God by the church.” The night before the trial, Peter is sleeping between two soldiers, chained. An angel wakes him, the chains fall off, and the iron gate opens by itself. Peter thinks it is a vision until he is in the street. At the house of Mary, the mother of John Mark, the church is praying, and when Rhoda announces that Peter is at the door, they say, “You are out of your mind!” Their prayers were answered, and they could hardly believe it. Herod later gives a speech, the crowd cries, “The voice of a god, and not of a man!” and an angel strikes him down because he did not give God the glory. “But the word of God increased and multiplied.” Kings fall, and the word advances.

In Antioch, the church has prophets and teachers, including Barnabas and Saul. While they are worshiping and fasting, the Holy Spirit says, “Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them.” After fasting and prayer, they lay hands on them and send them. They sail to Cyprus, where Saul, who is now called Paul, confronts a magician and the proconsul Sergius Paulus believes. Then they go to Pisidian Antioch, where Paul preaches in the synagogue. His sermon moves from Israel’s history to David and then to Jesus, the Savior raised from the dead. “Let it be known to you therefore, brothers, that through this man forgiveness of sins is proclaimed to you, and by him everyone who believes is freed from everything from which you could not be freed by the law of Moses.” This is justification by faith in Christ.

The next Sabbath, almost the whole city gathers. The Jews are jealous and contradict Paul. Paul and Barnabas say boldly, “It was necessary that the word of God be spoken first to you. Since you thrust it aside, behold, we are turning to the Gentiles.” They cite Isaiah 49:6, “I have made you a light for the Gentiles.” The Gentiles rejoice, and “as many as were appointed to eternal life believed.” God’s sovereign choice and the human response are held together. The word spreads throughout the region. The Jews stir up persecution and drive them out, but the disciples are “filled with joy and with the Holy Spirit.”

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 49:6 is the commission quoted in 13:47. Psalm 2:7, Isaiah 55:3, and Psalm 16:10 are quoted in Paul's sermon in 13:33-35. Romans 3:21-28 and Galatians 2:16 develop justification by faith. Genesis 12:3 shows the Abrahamic promise at work. Romans 9 to 11 discusses God's election and Israel. Ephesians 1:4-5 speaks of being chosen. 2 Corinthians 12:10 says that when I am weak, then I am strong. Psalm 34:7 says the angel of the LORD encamps around those who fear him.

STEP 6

Application

Pray earnestly for someone in danger or need, and expect God to answer, even if your faith is small.

Ask what the Spirit might be setting you apart for. Fast and pray with your church.

Remember that forgiveness is received by faith, not by law.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for answering the church's prayers.
- Ask him to set apart workers for his harvest.
- Ask him to make you willing to go or to send.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 101

"To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

ACTS 10:43

DAY 705 · WEEK 101

Psalm 67

May God be gracious, all the nations praise him

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 67. It is a short prayer that God would bless his people so that all nations would know and praise him. It reads like the first missionary journey of Acts 13 turned into song.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 67 begins with the priestly blessing of Numbers 6:24-26 ("the LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you"), but turns it outward. The blessing is not an end in itself. Israel is blessed so that the nations may be blessed. That is the Abrahamic promise at work, which is the reason why Acts 13 quotes Isaiah 49:6. Reading it as Paul and Barnabas set out on their journey makes the missions theme clear.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "May God be gracious to us and bless us and make his face to shine upon us" (v. 1).
2. "That your way may be known on earth" (v. 2).
3. "Your saving power among all nations" (v. 2).
4. "Let the peoples praise you, O God; let all the peoples praise you!" (v. 3).
5. "Let the nations be glad and sing for joy" (v. 4).
6. "For you judge the peoples with equity and guide the nations upon earth" (v. 4).
7. "The earth has yielded its increase; God, our God, has blessed us" (v. 6).
8. "God shall bless us; let all the ends of the earth fear him!" (v. 7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts with a prayer for blessing: “May God be gracious to us and bless us and make his face to shine upon us.” This is borrowed from the benediction that Aaron and his sons spoke over Israel. But the next word is “that.” The blessing has a purpose: “that your way may be known on earth, your saving power among all nations.” Israel asks for God’s favor, not for its own sake, but so that the whole world may see and know the LORD.

The refrain follows: “Let the peoples praise you, O God; let all the peoples praise you!” It appears twice, in verses 3 and 5, as the center of the psalm. The goal of all God’s work is that the nations praise him. In between, the psalm says why the nations can be glad: God judges the peoples with equity and guides the nations upon earth. His rule is just and good. The nations are not simply objects of judgment but people whom God guides. This is a vision of a world finally under the good rule of the true God.

Then the psalm returns to blessing: “The earth has yielded its increase; God, our God, has blessed us. God shall bless us; let all the ends of the earth fear him!” The harvest is the sign of God’s blessing, and it becomes a motive for missions. The psalm ends with the whole world fearing the LORD.

This is the pattern of the Abrahamic covenant: “I will bless you… so that you will be a blessing… and in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed.” It is the pattern of Acts: the apostles are sent to the nations. And it is the church’s prayer today. We pray for God to bless us, not for comfort alone, but so that we can be used to bless others and bring praise to his name. The final picture, in Revelation 7:9, is of people from every nation, tribe, people, and language praising God. Psalm 67 is the prayer that leads there.

STEP 5

Connection

Numbers 6:22-27 is the priestly blessing. Genesis 12:1-3 is the Abrahamic promise. Isaiah 49:6 and 2:2-4 speak of the nations coming to the LORD. Psalm 117 and 96 also call the nations to praise. Matthew 28:19-20 gives the Great Commission. Acts 13:47 quotes Isaiah 49:6. Romans 15:9-12 collects Old Testament texts on the Gentiles praising God. Revelation 7:9-10 pictures the fulfillment.

STEP 6

Application

Pray this psalm for your church: “Bless us so that your way may be known on earth.”

Pray for one unreached people group by name. Look up a missionary or agency your church supports.

Ask how God's blessings to you can overflow to others.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to be gracious to you and make his face shine on you.
- Ask him to let his way be known on earth.
- Pray for a nation or people group to know him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 101

"To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

ACTS 10:43

DAY 706 · WEEK 101

Psalm 87

Zion as mother of all peoples

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 87. This short psalm imagines Zion as the mother city of all peoples, including Israel's historic enemies. Read slowly. It is a puzzling psalm that becomes clear in light of Acts.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 87 is a song of the sons of Korah, a hymn of Zion. It is brief and surprising. God registers people from Egypt (Rahab), Babylon, Philistia, Tyre, and Cush as born in Zion. These are Israel's old enemies, and now they are citizens of the city of God. This is the Old Testament's most vivid picture of the nations coming in.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "On the holy mount stands the city he founded" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD loves the gates of Zion more than all the dwelling places of Jacob" (v. 2).
3. "Glorious things of you are spoken, O city of God" (v. 3).
4. "Among those who know me I mention Rahab and Babylon" (v. 4).
5. "Behold, Philistia and Tyre, with Cush" (v. 4).
6. "And of Zion it shall be said, This one and that one were born in her; for the Most High himself will establish her" (v. 5).
7. "The LORD records, as he registers the peoples, This one was born there" (v. 6).
8. "Singers and dancers alike say, All my springs are in you" (v. 7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with the city God founded on the holy mount. The LORD loves the gates of Zion more than all the other dwelling places of Jacob. Glorious things are spoken of her. And then the surprising list begins. God says, “Among those who know me I mention Rahab and Babylon.” Rahab is a poetic name for Egypt. These were the oppressors in Israel’s story, the powers that enslaved and exiled. And Philistia, Tyre, and Cush (Ethiopia) are also named. They are mentioned among those who know the LORD.

Verse 4 ends: “This one was born there.” And verse 5 explains: “Of Zion it shall be said, This one and that one were born in her.” Foreigners are said to be born in Zion. The citizens of Zion include people from every nation. The LORD himself keeps the register: “The LORD records, as he registers the peoples, This one was born there.” When the census is read, the nations are on the list.

This is the idea of the new birth applied to peoples. The New Testament says that believers are born from above (John 3:3). Paul says in Galatians 4:26 that the Jerusalem above is free, and she is our mother. Hebrews 12:22 says we have come to Mount Zion, to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem. Ephesians 2:19 says Gentiles are no longer strangers and aliens but fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God.

This is what Acts is unfolding. An Ethiopian official from Cush believes through Philip. Cornelius, a Roman, receives the Spirit. Antioch becomes a church of Jews and Greeks. Psalm 87 pictures the endpoint, in which former enemies sing together and say, “All my springs are in you.” All the sources of joy and life are found in Zion, and Christ is the temple and the center. The gospel does not abolish the identity of nations but brings them into one family, where God registers each as born there.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 19:19-25 pictures Egypt and Assyria joined with Israel as a blessing. Isaiah 2:2-4 and 56:6-8 describe the nations coming to Zion. Galatians 4:26 speaks of the Jerusalem above as our mother. Hebrews 12:22-24 says we have come to Zion. Ephesians 2:11-22 says Gentiles are fellow citizens. Philippians 3:20 says our citizenship is in heaven. Revelation 21:24-26 pictures the nations bringing their glory into the city.

STEP 6

Application

Imagine a person from a nation or group you struggle with, and picture them registered as born in Zion with you.

Thank God for the family of the church, which includes people unlike you.

Pray that old enmities in your family or church would be healed in Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for registering people from every nation in his city.

Ask him to make you welcoming.

Thank him that you are born there.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 101

"To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

ACTS 10:43

DAY 707 · WEEK 101

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Acts 10:43 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

ACTS 10:43

REST

Meditation

Peter says this in the house of Cornelius, a Roman, in the first sermon to the Gentiles. In one verse, he sums up the gospel.

"To him all the prophets bear witness." The Old Testament is a witness to Jesus. Moses, David, Isaiah, and the others all point to him. This is why we read the whole Bible as one story.

"That everyone who believes in him." Notice the word "everyone." The offer is universal, to Jew and Gentile, to the devout and the sinner. The one condition is belief: trust in Jesus.

"Receives forgiveness of sins." Forgiveness is the great need and the great gift. It is received, not earned. The word "receives" means we hold out empty hands.

"Through his name." Forgiveness comes through his name, that is, through who he is and what he has done. We do not come in our own name or by our own merit.

When you wonder whether the gospel is really for you, or whether you are too far from God, say this verse. It was spoken to a Gentile soldier, and it is for everyone who believes.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week the gospel moved out from Jerusalem. After Stephen's death, the church was scattered, and Philip took the word to Samaria and met an Ethiopian official reading Isaiah 53. You saw the risen Jesus stop Saul on the road to Damascus and ask, "Why are you persecuting me?" You watched God show Peter in a vision that he should not call any person common or unclean, and then pour out the Holy Spirit on Cornelius's Gentile household. The Antioch church, full of Jews and Greeks, set apart Barnabas and Saul, and Paul preached to the Gentiles in Pisidian Antioch, citing Isaiah 49:6. Psalm 67 and Psalm 87 gave you songs for the nations: the blessing that spills over to the world and the city where former enemies are registered as born in Zion.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus asked Saul, "Why are you persecuting me?" What does it mean that Christ identifies so closely with his people?

God told Peter, "What God has made clean, do not call common." Who do you tend to see as outside the reach of the gospel, and how could God change that?

Psalm 67 prays for God's blessing so that all nations will praise him. How does that change how you think about your own blessings?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that everyone who believes in Jesus receives forgiveness.

Thank him for sending his word to the nations.

Rest in his forgiveness.

DAY 708 · WEEK 102

Psalm 117

Praise the LORD, all nations, the mission in two verses

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 2 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 117. It has only two verses. You met it earlier, in the unit on Luke. Read it now as the whole mission of Acts in miniature: the call to the nations and the reason.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 117 is the shortest psalm and the shortest chapter in the Bible. Paul quotes it in Romans 15:11 to show that the Gentiles were always meant to glorify God. Placed here, in the middle of the first missionary journey, it is a summary of what Paul and Barnabas are doing: calling all nations to praise the LORD because of his steadfast love and faithfulness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Praise the LORD, all nations!” (v. 1).
2. “Extol him, all peoples!” (v. 1).
3. “For great is his steadfast love” (v. 2).
4. “Toward us” (v. 2).
5. “The faithfulness of the LORD” (v. 2).
6. “Endures forever” (v. 2).
7. “Praise the LORD!” (v. 2).
8. “All peoples” (v. 1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In two verses, the psalm gives the mission's command and its motive. The command is to praise: "Praise the LORD, all nations! Extol him, all peoples!" The scope is every nation and every people. The motive is in verse 2: "For great is his steadfast love toward us, and the faithfulness of the LORD endures forever."

Notice the logic. The nations are to praise because of God's love "toward us," toward Israel. The LORD's covenant faithfulness to one people is the reason for the whole world to worship. In Acts, this is the heart of the mission. The God who kept his promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, to David, and to Israel in sending Jesus, is the God who is calling the nations. Paul preaches in Pisidian Antioch that God has fulfilled the promise made to the fathers. The Gentiles rejoice and glorify the word of the Lord. They are the "all peoples" called to praise.

Look at Paul's use in Romans 15: Christ became a servant to the circumcised to show God's truthfulness, in order to confirm the promises given to the patriarchs, and in order that the Gentiles might glorify God for his mercy. Then Paul quotes a chain of passages, including this psalm: "Praise the Lord, all nations, and let all the peoples extol him." The psalmist wrote this long before, and Paul says it is being fulfilled.

The psalm also gives the mission its fuel. Missionaries do not go out because of a program but because the LORD is worthy of praise from every people. Missions exists because worship doesn't yet. The great goal is that all nations praise him, and the great ground is his steadfast love and faithfulness.

The psalm ends as it began, with "Praise the LORD!" We can do the same, grateful that his love is great toward us, and his faithfulness endures forever.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 15:8-12 quotes this psalm. Psalm 67, 96, 98, and 100 are similar missionary psalms. Genesis 12:3 and 22:18 are the Abrahamic promise. Isaiah 49:6 and 56:7 point to the nations coming. Acts 13:47-48 shows Gentiles glorifying the word of the Lord. Revelation 7:9-10 pictures the fulfillment.

STEP 6

Application

Recite the psalm aloud each morning this week. It takes ten seconds.

Name a nation or people group and pray the psalm over them.

Thank God that you belong to "all nations" because of his steadfast love.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise the LORD with all the nations.

Thank him for his great steadfast love toward us.

Pray for his word to reach someone far away.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 102

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."

ACTS 16:31

DAY 709 · WEEK 102

Acts 14:1-28

The first journey concludes; Lystra and Derbe

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 14:1-28. Paul and Barnabas preach in Iconium, Lystra, and Derbe. They heal a man, are mistaken for gods, and Paul is stoned. They return, strengthening the churches and appointing elders. Read Paul's speech at Lystra (vv. 15 to 17) carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first missionary journey continues from Pisidian Antioch to Iconium, Lystra, and Derbe, cities in what is now central Turkey. The pattern is that Paul first speaks in the synagogue, the Gentiles respond, and the Jews stir up opposition. At Lystra there is no synagogue, and the population is pagan, so Paul's message begins with God as Creator, a template for preaching to those with no biblical background.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "So they remained for a long time, speaking boldly for the Lord, who bore witness to the word of his grace" (14:3).
2. "The gods have come down to us in the likeness of men!" (14:11).
3. "We also are men, of like nature with you, and we bring you good news, that you should turn from these vain things to a living God, who made the heaven and the earth and the sea and all that is in them" (14:15).
4. "Yet he did not leave himself without witness, for he did good by giving you rains from heaven and fruitful seasons, satisfying your hearts with food and gladness" (14:17).
5. "They stoned Paul and dragged him out of the city, supposing that he was dead" (14:19).
6. "Through many tribulations we must enter the kingdom of God" (14:22).

7. “And when they had appointed elders for them in every church, with prayer and fasting they committed them to the Lord in whom they had believed” (14:23).

8. “They declared all that God had done with them, and how he had opened a door of faith to the Gentiles” (14:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Iconium, a great number of Jews and Greeks believe, but unbelieving Jews stir up the Gentiles. Paul and Barnabas stay a long time, speaking boldly, with signs and wonders, and then flee when a plot to stone them arises.

At Lystra, Paul sees a man crippled from birth who has faith to be made well, and says, “Stand upright on your feet.” The man leaps up and walks. The crowd shouts in their local language, “The gods have come down to us in the likeness of men!” They call Barnabas Zeus and Paul Hermes, and the priest of Zeus brings oxen and garlands to offer sacrifice. Paul and Barnabas tear their garments and rush into the crowd: “Men, why are you doing these things? We also are men, of like nature with you.” Their message is not about themselves but about the living God: “turn from these vain things to a living God, who made the heaven and the earth and the sea.” Though in past generations God allowed all the nations to walk in their own ways, he has not left himself without witness, giving rain and fruitful seasons, satisfying hearts with food and gladness. This is the first example in Acts of preaching to people with no Scriptural background. Paul starts with creation, God’s goodness, and the folly of idolatry, and only later comes to Christ. Even so, they can scarcely restrain the people from sacrificing.

Then Jews arrive from Antioch and Iconium, win over the crowds, and stone Paul and drag him out of the city, thinking him dead. The people who wanted to worship him now try to kill him. But as the disciples gather around him, he gets up and goes back into the city. The next day he leaves for Derbe.

They return the way they came, strengthening the disciples and encouraging them to continue in the faith: “Through many tribulations we must enter the kingdom of God.” They appoint elders in every church, with prayer and fasting. Back in Antioch, they report “all that God had done with them, and how he had opened a door of faith to the Gentiles.” It is God who opens the door and God who does the work.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1 and Psalm 146:6 describe God as the maker of heaven and earth. Psalm 145:15-16 says he satisfies the desire of every living thing. Romans 1:18-23 and 2:14-15 describe general revelation. Acts 17:22-31 is Paul's similar speech in Athens. 2 Corinthians 11:25 recalls the stoning. 2 Timothy 3:11 mentions his sufferings at Lystra. Titus 1:5 shows Titus appointing elders. John 16:33 says in the world you will have tribulation.

STEP 6

Application

Practice explaining the gospel to someone with no Christian background, starting with creation.

Remember that tribulation is not a sign you're off track. It is part of the road to the kingdom.

Thank God for the elders in your church, and pray for them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his goodness in rain, seasons, food, and gladness.

Ask him to keep you from taking his glory.

Ask him to strengthen believers who face hardship.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 102

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."

ACTS 16:31

DAY 710 · WEEK 102

Acts 15:1-41

The Jerusalem Council; the second journey begins

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 15:1-41. Some teach that Gentiles must be circumcised to be saved. The apostles and elders meet in Jerusalem to decide. Notice how they reason, who speaks, and what they conclude. Then Paul and Barnabas part ways.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the central chapter of Acts and arguably the most important meeting in the early church. The question is whether Gentile believers must become Jews, keeping the law of Moses, to be saved. If the answer were yes, the gospel would become another form of Judaism. Around AD 49, the apostles and elders meet in Jerusalem. The decision shapes the whole Christian faith.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “But some men came down from Judea and were teaching the brothers, Unless you are circumcised according to the custom of Moses, you cannot be saved” (15:1).
2. “And God, who knows the heart, bore witness to them, by giving them the Holy Spirit just as he did to us” (15:8).
3. “Now therefore why are you putting God to the test by placing a yoke on the neck of the disciples that neither our fathers nor we have been able to bear?” (15:10).
4. “But we believe that we will be saved through the grace of the Lord Jesus, just as they will” (15:11).
5. “After this I will return, and I will rebuild the tent of David that has fallen” (15:16).

6. “Therefore my judgment is that we should not trouble those of the Gentiles who turn to God” (15:19).

7. “For it has seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to us to lay on you no greater burden than these requirements” (15:28).

8. “And there arose a sharp disagreement, so that they separated from each other” (15:39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The trouble starts in Antioch when men from Judea teach that circumcision is necessary for salvation. Paul and Barnabas dispute with them, and the church sends them to Jerusalem to settle the matter. There they report how God had opened a door to the Gentiles, but some believers who belonged to the party of the Pharisees insist that Gentiles must be circumcised and keep the law of Moses.

After much debate, Peter stands. He reminds them that God chose that Gentiles should hear the gospel from his mouth, and that God, who knows the heart, bore witness by giving the Gentiles the Holy Spirit as he did to the Jews, “having cleansed their hearts by faith.” To impose the law now would be to put God to the test with a yoke that neither they nor their fathers could bear. The conclusion is the heart of the gospel: “We believe that we will be saved through the grace of the Lord Jesus, just as they will.” Jews are saved the same way as Gentiles, by grace, not by law.

Barnabas and Paul describe the signs and wonders God did among the Gentiles. Then James, the brother of Jesus, speaks. He quotes Amos 9:11-12: God will rebuild the fallen tent of David so that the rest of mankind may seek the Lord, and all the Gentiles who are called by his name. The inclusion of the Gentiles is not a departure from the Old Testament but its fulfillment. This is a key text for the progressive covenantalism you have been reading: the Davidic kingdom, restored in Christ, includes the nations. James gives his judgment: do not trouble the Gentiles who turn to God, but write to them to abstain from things polluted by idols, from sexual immorality, from what has been strangled, and from blood. These requests promoted fellowship between Jew and Gentile believers, who would share tables. The letter goes out, saying, “It has seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to us.” The Gentiles rejoice at its encouragement.

Chapter 15 ends with sadness. Paul proposes revisiting the churches, but Barnabas wants to take John Mark again, who had left them on the first journey. Paul refuses. There is a sharp disagreement, and they part. Barnabas takes Mark to Cyprus. Paul chooses Silas and goes through Syria and Cilicia. God uses even this to double the missionary effort. Later Paul writes that Mark is “very useful” to him (2 Timothy 4:11).

STEP 5

Connection

Amos 9:11-12 is James's text. Genesis 17 is the covenant of circumcision. Galatians 2:1-21 is Paul's account of the same events. Galatians 5:1-6 insists that circumcision no longer matters. Romans 3:28 and 4:1-12 teach justification by faith apart from works of the law. Ephesians 2:8-9 says we are saved by grace through faith. Colossians 2:11-17 shows circumcision and food laws fulfilled in Christ. 2 Timothy 4:11 mentions Mark.

STEP 6

Application

Where are you tempted to add something to grace, such as a rule, a ritual, or a performance?

Rejoice in verse 11 and say it aloud: saved through the grace of the Lord Jesus.

If you've had a sharp disagreement with a fellow believer, pray for reconciliation and for God to use it for good.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are saved through the grace of the Lord Jesus.

Confess where you try to add to grace.

Ask him to help you welcome others without adding burdens.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 102

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."

ACTS 16:31

DAY 711 · WEEK 102

Acts 16:1-40

Timothy; the Macedonian call; Lydia; the Philippian jailer

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 40 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 16:1-40. Timothy joins Paul, a vision calls them to Macedonia, Lydia believes in Philippi, and a jailer is converted after an earthquake. Notice how each conversion looks different and how each family is included.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second missionary journey takes Paul and Silas through Asia Minor. In Lystra, they pick up Timothy, a young disciple of Jewish and Greek parentage. The Spirit forbids them to speak in Asia and Bithynia, and in a night vision, a man of Macedonia calls them to cross to Europe. The gospel reaches the continent for the first time at Philippi, a Roman colony.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Paul wanted Timothy to accompany him, and he took him and circumcised him because of the Jews who were in those places, for they all knew that his father was a Greek” (16:3).
2. “A man of Macedonia was standing there, urging him and saying, Come over to Macedonia and help us” (16:9).
3. “The Lord opened her heart to pay attention to what was said by Paul” (16:14).
4. “About midnight Paul and Silas were praying and singing hymns to God, and the prisoners were listening to them” (16:25).
5. “And suddenly there was a great earthquake, so that the foundations of the prison were shaken” (16:26).
6. “Sirs, what must I do to be saved?” (16:30).

7. “Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household” (16:31).

8. “He rejoiced along with his entire household that he had believed in God” (16:34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Timothy, whose mother is a believing Jew and whose father is Greek, is well spoken of. Paul circumcises him, not because it is necessary for salvation, as Acts 15 has just settled, but to avoid hindering the gospel among Jews. This shows Paul’s flexibility on matters of culture. Titus, a Gentile, was not circumcised under pressure (Galatians 2:3). The difference is the reason: Timothy’s circumcision was a choice for mission, not a requirement for salvation.

The vision leads them to Philippi. On the Sabbath, outside the gate by the river, they find women gathered to pray. Lydia, a dealer in purple goods and a worshiper of God, listens. “The Lord opened her heart to pay attention to what was said by Paul.” Conversion is God’s work. She is baptized with her household and invites them to stay at her house.

Then a slave girl with a spirit of divination follows them, shouting. Paul commands the spirit to come out in the name of Jesus Christ. Her owners, who lost their profit, drag Paul and Silas before the magistrates. They are beaten with rods and thrown into the inner prison with their feet in stocks. At midnight they are praying and singing hymns, and the prisoners are listening. A great earthquake shakes the prison, the doors open, and everyone’s chains come loose. The jailer, thinking the prisoners have escaped, is about to kill himself. Paul cries, “Do not harm yourself, for we are all here.” The jailer trembles, falls before Paul and Silas, and asks, “Sirs, what must I do to be saved?” They answer, “Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household.”

This is the clearest answer in the Bible to the question of how to be saved: believe in the Lord Jesus. Then they speak the word of the Lord to him and his household. That same night he washes their wounds and is baptized with all his family. He brings them into his house and sets food before them, “and rejoiced along with his entire household that he had believed in God.” In the morning, the magistrates send word to release them, and Paul insists on a public apology, because he is a Roman citizen. This protects the young church.

Three conversions: a wealthy businesswoman, a slave girl freed from a spirit, and a rough jailer. The gospel crosses class and gender lines.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Timothy 1:5 and 3:14-15 describe Timothy's heritage. Galatians 2:3-5 is Titus not circumcised. 1 Corinthians 9:19-23 explains Paul's flexibility for the gospel. Philippians 1:1-11 is Paul's letter to the same church. Romans 10:9-13 says if you confess with your mouth and believe in your heart, you will be saved. John 6:29 says to believe in him whom he has sent. 1 Peter 2:21-23 and 4:12-16 treat unjust suffering. Psalm 40:3 speaks of a new song.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Acts 16:31. It is the memory verse of this week.

Sing a hymn tonight even if things are hard, as Paul did in prison.

Pray for the "household" in your life, that the whole family would believe.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to open your heart and the hearts of those you love.
- Thank him for shaking prisons and setting captives free.
- Tell him what you need to be set free from.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 102

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."

ACTS 16:31

DAY 712 · WEEK 102

Acts 17:1-18:28

Thessalonica; Berea; Athens; Corinth

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 17:1-18:28. Paul preaches in Thessalonica, is received nobly in Berea, speaks to the philosophers at Athens, and stays a year and a half in Corinth. Read the Areopagus speech (17:22-31) slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul and Silas travel southwest from Philippi through Amphipolis and Apollonia to Thessalonica. Opposition drives them to Berea, then Paul goes on to Athens, the intellectual capital of the Greek world. Finally, he reaches Corinth, a wealthy and immoral port city, where he stays eighteen months. Along the way he meets Priscilla and Aquila.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Explaining and proving that it was necessary for the Christ to suffer and to rise from the dead” (17:2-3).
2. “Now these Jews were more noble than those in Thessalonica; they received the word with all eagerness, examining the Scriptures daily to see if these things were so” (17:11).
3. “For as I passed along and observed the objects of your worship, I found also an altar with this inscription: To the unknown god. What therefore you worship as unknown, this I proclaim to you” (17:23).
4. “The God who made the world and everything in it, being Lord of heaven and earth, does not live in temples made by man” (17:24).
5. “In him we live and move and have our being” (17:28).

6. “Because he has fixed a day on which he will judge the world in righteousness by a man whom he has appointed; and of this he has given assurance to all by raising him from the dead” (17:31).
7. “Do not be afraid, but go on speaking and do not be silent, for I am with you” (18:9-10).
8. “They took him and explained to him the way of God more accurately” (18:26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Thessalonica, Paul reasons from the Scriptures for three Sabbaths, explaining and proving that the Christ had to suffer and rise from the dead, and that Jesus is the Christ. Some believe, including many God-fearing Greeks, but jealous Jews form a mob. The accusation is that they are “turning the world upside down” and saying there is another king, Jesus. In Berea, the Jews are more noble: they receive the word eagerly and examine the Scriptures daily to see if these things are so. This is the model for every Christian: test what you hear against the Bible.

At Athens, Paul is provoked by a city full of idols. He argues in the synagogue and the marketplace, and the philosophers bring him to the Areopagus. His speech is a model of cross-cultural preaching. He begins with their religiosity and the altar to an unknown god. Then he proclaims the God who made the world and everything in it, who does not live in temples made by man or need anything from human hands, and who gives to all mankind life and breath. He made from one man every nation, having determined their allotted periods and boundaries, that they should seek God. He quotes their own poets: “In him we live and move and have our being” and “We are his offspring.” Since we are God’s offspring, we ought not to think the divine being is like gold or silver or stone. The times of ignorance God overlooked, but now he commands all people everywhere to repent, because he has fixed a day to judge the world in righteousness by a man he has appointed, and has given assurance by raising him from the dead. Some mock at the resurrection, some want to hear more, and a few believe, including Dionysius and a woman named Damaris.

In Corinth, Paul meets Aquila and Priscilla, fellow tentmakers, and works with them. He preaches in the synagogue, and when the Jews oppose, he turns to the Gentiles. Crispus, the ruler of the synagogue, believes. The Lord appears to Paul in a night vision: “Do not be afraid, but go on speaking and do not be silent, for I am with you, and no one will attack you to harm you, for I have many in this city who are my people.” He stays a year and a half. At the end of the chapter, Apollos, an eloquent man mighty in the Scriptures, comes to Ephesus, and Priscilla and Aquila, hearing him, take him aside and explain the way of God more accurately. A husband and wife team the gifted teacher.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 44:9-20 mocks idols. Psalm 115:3-8 also. Deuteronomy 32:8 speaks of God setting the boundaries of nations. Isaiah 42:5 says God gives breath to the people. Romans 1:18-25 discusses the suppression of the truth. Romans 2:14-16 describes the law written on hearts. 1 Corinthians 2:1-5 shows Paul's approach at Corinth. 1 Corinthians 16:19 mentions Aquila and Priscilla. 2 Timothy 3:16-17 says all Scripture is God-breathed. Acts 24:15 speaks of the resurrection of the just and unjust.

STEP 6

Application

Be a Berean: check what you hear, including from me, against Scripture.

Learn to listen to the culture and find a bridge, like the altar, to speak of Christ.

Be like Priscilla and Aquila: take aside a gifted person who needs help and teach them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God as the one in whom we live and move and have our being.

Ask him for the nobility of Berea, to examine Scripture daily.

Pray for the people you know who worship the unknown.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 102

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."

ACTS 16:31

DAY 713 · WEEK 102

Acts 19:1-41

Ephesus, disciples receive the Spirit; the riot

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 19:1-41. Paul spends nearly three years in Ephesus. Disciples of John receive the Spirit, extraordinary miracles occur, magic books are burned, and a riot breaks out over the goddess Artemis. Notice the power of the word.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ephesus was the leading city of Asia Minor, home of the great temple of Artemis (Diana), one of the seven wonders of the ancient world. It was a center of magic and trade. Paul based his ministry here for about three years (AD 52 to 55), and the Ephesian church became one of the most important in the early church. From here, all of Asia heard the word of the Lord.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?” (19:2).
2. “And when Paul had laid his hands on them, the Holy Spirit came on them, and they spoke in tongues and prophesied” (19:6).
3. “He withdrew from them and took the disciples with him, reasoning daily in the hall of Tyrannus” (19:9).
4. “Jesus I know, and Paul I recognize, but who are you?” (19:15).
5. “And a number of those who had practiced magic arts brought their books together and burned them in the sight of all” (19:19).
6. “So the word of the Lord continued to increase and prevail mightily” (19:20).
7. “Saying that gods made with hands are not gods” (19:26).
8. “Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!” (19:28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul finds some disciples in Ephesus who knew only the baptism of John. When he asks, “Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?” they have not even heard that there is a Holy Spirit. Paul explains that John’s baptism was a baptism of repentance, pointing to the one who would come after him, Jesus. They are baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus, and when Paul lays his hands on them, the Spirit comes. These were Old Testament believers who were brought into the new covenant era, a unique transitional moment, and not a pattern for later believers, since every Christian receives the Spirit at conversion (Romans 8:9).

Paul speaks boldly in the synagogue for three months, then moves to the hall of Tyrannus, where he reasons daily for two years, “so that all the residents of Asia heard the word of the Lord.” God does extraordinary miracles by the hands of Paul. Some Jewish exorcists try to use the name of Jesus as a formula, and the evil spirit answers, “Jesus I know, and Paul I recognize, but who are you?” The man overpowers them. The name of Jesus is not a magic word. It is a person, and only those who know him have authority in his name. The event brings fear, and the name of Jesus is extolled.

Many believers come, confessing and divulging their practices. A number of those who had practiced magic burn their books, valued at fifty thousand pieces of silver. “So the word of the Lord continued to increase and prevail mightily.” This is the evidence of real conversion: they gave up what was dear and profitable.

Then comes a riot. Demetrius, a silversmith, whose shrine-making trade is threatened, stirs up the craftsmen: “Not only in Ephesus but in almost all of Asia this Paul has persuaded and turned away a great many people, saying that gods made with hands are not gods.” The whole city is filled with confusion, and for two hours they shout, “Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!” The town clerk calms the crowd, pointing out that the Christians have neither robbed temples nor blasphemed their goddess, and that if Demetrius has a complaint, there are courts. He dismisses the assembly. Notice how Luke shows that the gospel is not a threat to public order, though it is a threat to idolatry and the economies that depend on it.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 3:11 records John’s promise of baptism with the Holy Spirit. Ephesians 1:13-14 says believers are sealed with the Spirit. The letter to the Ephesians and Revelation 2:1-7 address the same church. Deuteronomy 18:10-12 forbids sorcery. Psalm 115:4-8 mocks idols made by hands. 1 Corinthians 15:32 and 16:8-9 mention Paul’s time in Ephesus. 2 Timothy 1:15-18 mentions Onesiphorus. 1 John 5:21 says to keep yourselves from idols.

STEP 6

Application

Is there a “book” you need to burn, something from your old life that holds you?

Ask whether you know Jesus personally or just use his name.

Ask where the economics of idolatry affect your life, such as consumerism and entertainment.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you know Jesus rather than just use his name.

Thank him for the Holy Spirit.

Ask him to expose any idols in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 102

“Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household.”

ACTS 16:31

DAY 714 · WEEK 102

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Acts 16:31 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."

ACTS 16:31

REST

Meditation

A Philippian jailer, trembling after an earthquake, asks Paul and Silas the most important question: "Sirs, what must I do to be saved?" This is their answer.

"Believe." To believe is more than agreeing with facts. It is to trust, to rely on, to put your weight on. The jailer is not told to do a task, but to trust a person.

"In the Lord Jesus." The object of faith is Jesus, the Lord who died and rose. He is the only Savior. "Lord" means the one who rules, and "Jesus" means the one who saves. To believe in him is to trust him as both.

"And you will be saved." The promise is certain. Not "might be" or "could be." Saved from sin, from judgment, and from death, and saved into life with God.

“You and your household.” The promise is for the jailer and extends to his family, who also heard the word and believed. It reminds us that God often works through families, and that faith in the head of a home opens the door to the gospel for the rest.

When you wonder what you must do to be saved or how to tell someone else, say this verse. It is the simplest summary of the gospel in the Bible.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you prayed Psalm 117, the shortest call to the nations. You followed the first journey to its end in Lystra and Derbe, where Paul was mistaken for a god and then stoned. At the Jerusalem Council, you saw the apostles decide that Gentiles are saved by grace, as Jews are, and you heard James cite Amos 9 about the rebuilding of David’s tent. You watched the second journey carry the gospel to Europe: Lydia’s heart was opened, and a jailer asked what he must do to be saved. You heard Paul preach to the Areopagus in Athens, you saw the Bereans search the Scriptures, and you spent three years in Ephesus, where the word prevailed mightily and magic books burned.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Jerusalem Council concluded that we are saved “through the grace of the Lord Jesus.” How do you tend to add to grace, and what would it mean to rest in it?

Lydia’s heart was opened by the Lord. Reflect on the moment God opened your heart. What did you notice then, and how has it changed you?

Paul preached differently to the Jews in Thessalonica and the philosophers in Athens. Who is your audience, and how might you meet them where they are while keeping the message of Christ the same?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Say with the jailer, “I believe in the Lord Jesus,” and mean it.

Pray for your household or those closest to you.

Rest in his grace.

DAY 715 · WEEK 103

Acts 20:1-38

Paul's farewell to the Ephesian elders

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 38 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 20:1-38. Paul travels through Macedonia and Greece, raises Eutychus in Troas, and gives a farewell speech to the Ephesian elders at Miletus. Read the farewell slowly. It is Paul's pastoral testament.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul's third missionary journey is drawing to a close. He is headed for Jerusalem with a collection for the poor saints there, knowing that chains and afflictions await. On the way he meets the elders of the Ephesian church on a beach at Miletus. This is the only speech in Acts that Paul gives to believers rather than to unbelievers, and it reveals his heart for the church.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "On the first day of the week, when we were gathered together to break bread, Paul talked with them" (20:7).
2. "Testifying both to Jews and to Greeks of repentance toward God and of faith in our Lord Jesus Christ" (20:21).
3. "But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God" (20:24).
4. "For I did not shrink from declaring to you the whole counsel of God" (20:27).
5. "Pay careful attention to yourselves and to all the flock, in which the Holy Spirit has made you overseers, to care for the church of God, which he obtained with his own blood" (20:28).

6. “And now I commend you to God and to the word of his grace, which is able to build you up and to give you the inheritance among all those who are sanctified” (20:32).
7. “It is more blessed to give than to receive” (20:35).
8. “And there was much weeping on the part of all” (20:37).

STEP 4

Interpretation

At Troas, the church gathers on the first day of the week to break bread. Paul talks until midnight, and a young man, Eutychus, sitting in a window, falls asleep and falls three stories. He is taken up dead, and Paul embraces him and says, “Do not be alarmed, for his life is in him.” They go back upstairs, break bread, and talk until dawn. This verse is one of the clues that early Christians met on Sunday, the day of resurrection.

At Miletus, Paul summons the Ephesian elders and reminds them of how he lived among them. He served the Lord with all humility and with tears and trials. He did not shrink from declaring anything that was profitable, teaching in public and from house to house, testifying to both Jews and Greeks of repentance toward God and faith in the Lord Jesus. Now, he says, he is going to Jerusalem, bound in the Spirit, not knowing what will happen, except that the Holy Spirit testifies in every city that imprisonment and afflictions await him. “But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God.” He says they will not see his face again.

Then comes his charge: “Pay careful attention to yourselves and to all the flock, in which the Holy Spirit has made you overseers, to care for the church of God, which he obtained with his own blood.” The verse is rich: the Holy Spirit appoints pastors, the church belongs to God, and God bought it with his own blood, which is a striking reference to the cross. Paul warns that fierce wolves will come in, and even from among their own number men will arise speaking twisted things to draw away disciples. They must be alert. Within a few decades, the church of Ephesus had indeed faced such threats.

He commends them to God and to the word of his grace, “which is able to build you up.” The sufficiency of God’s word is the foundation of pastoral ministry. He reminds them of his example of working with his hands and quotes a saying of Jesus not found in the Gospels: “It is more blessed to give than to receive.” Then he kneels and prays with them, and they all weep and kiss him, sorrowing most of all because they will not see his face again.

STEP 5

Connection

Ezekiel 34 is a charge to shepherds. 1 Peter 5:1-4 is Peter's charge to elders. 1 Timothy 3:1-7 and Titus 1:5-9 give qualifications for overseers. 2 Timothy 4:1-8 is Paul's last charge to Timothy. Philippians 3:12-14 speaks of pressing on to finish the race. Ephesians 5:25 says Christ loved the church and gave himself for her. Hebrews 13:17 asks the church to submit to leaders who keep watch over souls. Revelation 2:1-7 is Christ's later word to Ephesus.

STEP 6

Application

Ask how you can finish your course with joy. What is the ministry the Lord has given you?

Pray for your pastors and elders by name this week. Thank them.

Give something away, a gift of time or money, and experience the blessing Jesus spoke of.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the church he bought with his own blood.

Ask him to teach you to declare his whole counsel.

Ask him to help you care for those he has put in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 103

"But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God."

ACTS 20:24

DAY 716 · WEEK 103

Psalm 96

Sing to the LORD; declare his glory among the nations

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 96. You met it earlier as the song David sang when the ark came to Jerusalem. Read it now as a missionary hymn: it calls God's people to declare his glory among the nations.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 96 is almost identical to the song in 1 Chronicles 16 that David appointed when the ark entered Jerusalem. In the Psalter, it begins a group of psalms (96 to 99) that celebrate the kingship of the LORD over the nations. Following Paul's farewell to the Ephesians, this psalm turns our attention outward again: the mission is not finished, and the church is called to declare his glory to all peoples.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh sing to the LORD a new song; sing to the LORD, all the earth!" (v. 1).
2. "Sing to the LORD, bless his name; tell of his salvation from day to day" (v. 2).
3. "Declare his glory among the nations, his marvelous works among all the peoples!" (v. 3).
4. "For great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised; he is to be feared above all gods" (v. 4).
5. "For all the gods of the peoples are worthless idols, but the LORD made the heavens" (v. 5).
6. "Worship the LORD in the splendor of holiness; tremble before him, all the earth!" (v. 9).
7. "Say among the nations, The LORD reigns!" (v. 10).

8 “For he comes, for he comes to judge the earth. He will judge the world in righteousness, and the peoples in his faithfulness” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a new song. The call is to the whole earth. The church has sung new songs in each generation, because each generation experiences God’s salvation afresh. “Tell of his salvation from day to day.” Day by day, the people of God are to speak of what he has done.

Then the center of the psalm: “Declare his glory among the nations, his marvelous works among all the peoples!” This is a missions command in the Psalms. Israel was a priestly kingdom, not only to keep the faith but to declare it to the world. Why? Because the LORD is great and greatly to be praised. The gods of the peoples are worthless idols, a word that sounds like “nothings,” but the LORD made the heavens. Idols cannot save. The nations need to know the living God.

Verses 7 to 9 call the families of the peoples to ascribe to the LORD glory and strength, to bring an offering and come into his courts. Worship is the right response of every nation. The splendor of holiness is the beauty of God’s character, before which all should tremble.

Verse 10 gives the message: “Say among the nations, The LORD reigns!” This is the gospel in the Old Testament. The reign of God is news. He has established the world; it shall never be moved. He will judge the peoples with equity. This is not a threat but good news to the oppressed. All creation joins in: the heavens are glad, the earth rejoices, the sea roars, the fields exult, and the trees of the forest sing for joy before the LORD, for he comes.

The psalm ends with the coming of the LORD to judge the earth in righteousness and in his faithfulness. For Christians, this coming is the return of Christ. We tell the nations of his salvation and his coming, and invite them to be reconciled to him before that day. The tone of the psalm is joy, because the coming judge is the same one who has saved.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Chronicles 16:23-33 gives the same song at the bringing of the ark. Psalm 67, 97, 98, and 99 are related psalms. Isaiah 42:10-12 also calls for a new song. Isaiah 52:7-10 proclaims the reign of God. Psalm 115:3-8 mocks idols. 1 Thessalonians 1:9 says they turned from idols to serve a living God. Revelation 5:9, 14:3, and 15:3-4 contain the new song. Matthew 28:18-20 is the Great Commission.

STEP 6

Application

Sing or read a hymn or song today that you have never used before. Make it a new song.

Tell someone of his salvation today. Say a sentence about what God has done for you.

Say verse 10 aloud, “The LORD reigns!” over a situation that troubles you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Sing to the LORD a new song, in your own words.

Tell someone of his salvation today, or ask him to help you.

Declare his glory among the nations.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 103

“But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God.”

ACTS 20:24

DAY 717 · WEEK 103

Psalm 98

The LORD has made known his salvation

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 98. It is a joyful song about God's victory and salvation, revealed to the nations. Isaac Watts's hymn "Joy to the World" is based on this psalm.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 98 is a psalm without a title, but it builds on Psalm 96 and 97 and continues the theme of the LORD's kingship. It is filled with music: new songs, harps, trumpets, and the sea clapping. It is read at Christmas by many churches. In the context of Acts, it stresses that God has made his salvation known "in the sight of the nations."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh sing to the LORD a new song, for he has done marvelous things!" (v. 1).
2. "His right hand and his holy arm have worked salvation for him" (v. 1).
3. "The LORD has made known his salvation; he has revealed his righteousness in the sight of the nations" (v. 2).
4. "He has remembered his steadfast love and faithfulness to the house of Israel" (v. 3).
5. "All the ends of the earth have seen the salvation of our God" (v. 3).
6. "Make a joyful noise to the LORD, all the earth; break forth into joyous song and sing praises!" (v. 4).
7. "Let the rivers clap their hands; let the hills sing for joy together" (v. 8).
8. "Before the LORD, for he comes to judge the earth. He will judge the world with righteousness, and the peoples with equity" (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with the same call as Psalm 96, a new song, but gives a different reason: "for he has done marvelous things." Chief among these is salvation. "His right hand and his holy arm have worked salvation for him." The arm of the LORD is a picture of his strength to deliver, as in the exodus. Notice the phrase "for him": God's victory is not borrowed from anyone. He won it himself.

Verse 2 gives the missionary side: "The LORD has made known his salvation; he has revealed his righteousness in the sight of the nations." God's salvation is public. It is not hidden in a corner. And verse 3 shows how the two sides fit together: God remembered his steadfast love and faithfulness to the house of Israel. And as a result, all the ends of the earth have seen the salvation of our God. His covenant faithfulness to Israel is the way he brings salvation to the world. This is the story of Acts: the promises made to Israel are fulfilled in Jesus, and through him, the nations see the salvation of God. Simeon sang this when he held the child in the temple: "My eyes have seen your salvation… a light for revelation to the Gentiles."

Verses 4 to 6 call all the earth to make a joyful noise with lyre, trumpets, and the horn, before the King. And verses 7 to 9 extend the chorus to creation: the sea roars, the rivers clap their hands, and the hills sing for joy together, because the LORD is coming to judge the earth. Creation itself longs for the coming of the King (Romans 8:19-22). When he comes, creation will be set right.

Reading this psalm with Acts reminds us that the church's mission is accompanied by joy. We are not announcing a threat. We are announcing a victory. The right hand and the holy arm have worked salvation in the cross and the empty tomb, and the whole world is invited to see it and sing.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 15:1-18 is the original victory song. Isaiah 52:10 says all the ends of the earth shall see the salvation of our God. Isaiah 59:16 and 63:5 speak of his arm bringing salvation. Luke 2:30-32 is Simeon's song. Luke 1:68-75 is Zechariah's song. Romans 8:19-23 describes creation groaning and longing. Revelation 15:3-4 is the song of Moses and the Lamb. Isaac Watts's "Joy to the World" paraphrases this psalm.

STEP 6

Application

Sing "Joy to the World" aloud, even out of season.

Tell someone about a marvelous thing the LORD has done. Be specific.

Look at creation today, a tree or a hill or the sky, and imagine it singing to its Lord.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Sing to the LORD a new song for the marvelous things he has done.
- Thank him for making his salvation known.
- Ask him to help you break forth in joyous song.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 103

"But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God."

ACTS 20:24

DAY 718 · WEEK 103

Psalm 100

Make a joyful noise, all the earth

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 100. You read it earlier in the Gospel of John. Read it now as the closing call of the missionary psalms: all the earth is invited to enter his gates with thanksgiving.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 100 completes a cluster of psalms (93 to 100) that celebrate the kingship of the LORD. It is the last and most compact of the invitations to all the earth. Having read psalms about declaring his glory and salvation to the nations, we come to the response: what the nations do when they come. They come to worship with gladness and gratitude.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Make a joyful noise to the LORD, all the earth!” (v. 1).
2. “Come into his presence with singing!” (v. 2).
3. “Know that the LORD, he is God!” (v. 3).
4. “It is he who made us, and we are his” (v. 3).
5. “We are his people, and the sheep of his pasture” (v. 3).
6. “Enter his gates with thanksgiving, and his courts with praise!” (v. 4).
7. “Give thanks to him; bless his name!” (v. 4).
8. “For the LORD is good; his steadfast love endures forever, and his faithfulness to all generations” (v. 5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with an invitation to “all the earth.” The audience is the same as in Psalm 96 and 98. Here the focus is on the response of those who have heard the news and believed. They come with a joyful noise.

Verse 3 gives the basis for a right relationship: “Know that the LORD, he is God!” Knowing who God is comes first. The nations who once worshiped idols are now taught to know the LORD. “It is he who made us, and we are his.” This is the confession of every convert. We belong to the one who made us. We are his people, the sheep of his pasture, the language of the shepherd. In Acts, the Gentiles who believe are included in this: “those who are far off” have been brought near (Ephesians 2:13), and they are now part of God’s flock.

The call to enter his gates with thanksgiving shows the approach. We come to God not because we deserve it but with gratitude. Thanksgiving is the doorway. In Psalm 100, there is no sacrifice for sin mentioned, no priest, only joy. Under the new covenant, this joy rests on the finished sacrifice of Christ. We can enter the courts with praise because the way is open.

The final verse gives the threefold reason: the LORD is good (his character), his steadfast love endures forever (his covenant commitment), and his faithfulness extends to all generations (his reliability). Paul and the apostles saw this in action: the generations of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, and David, and now the church. God has been faithful across the centuries, and he is faithful now.

Notice how the invitation and the response connect Acts to the Psalms. The command to the nations is the mission of the church. The response of the nations is the church’s worship. In every city, from Antioch to Ephesus, new congregations were formed, singing, giving thanks, and calling on the name of the Lord. Psalm 100 is the picture of their gatherings.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 95 begins in a similar way. Psalm 117 is the shortest invitation to the nations. Ezekiel 34:30-31 calls Israel the flock of God. John 10:14-16 speaks of one flock, one shepherd. Ephesians 2:11-22 describes Gentiles brought near. Colossians 3:16-17 speaks of singing with thankfulness in your hearts. Hebrews 12:28 calls for acceptable worship with reverence and awe. Revelation 7:9-12 pictures the nations worshiping.

STEP 6

Application

Begin worship this week with thanksgiving. Enter his gates with a list of at least five things you are grateful for.

Read the psalm to someone who is new to the faith.

Thank God for the generations of faithful people who passed the gospel down to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Make a joyful noise to the LORD, naming why.
- Thank him that he made you and you are his.
- Enter his presence with thanksgiving.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 103

"But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God."

ACTS 20:24

DAY 719 · WEEK 103

Acts 21:1-22:30

Paul arrested; his defense in the Temple

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 70 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 21:1-22:30. Paul goes up to Jerusalem despite warnings, is seized in the temple, and gives his testimony from the steps of the barracks. Notice his courage, and how he retells his conversion.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has finished his third journey and reaches Jerusalem around AD 57, with gifts for the poor believers. Prophets warn him in city after city that chains await. He goes anyway. In Jerusalem, rumors have spread that he teaches Jews to abandon Moses. The leaders suggest that he demonstrate his faithfulness by joining a vow in the temple. It leads to his arrest and the long imprisonment that takes him to Rome.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “What are you doing, weeping and breaking my heart? For I am ready not only to be imprisoned but even to die at Jerusalem for the name of the Lord Jesus” (21:13).
2. “And since he would not be persuaded, we ceased and said, Let the will of the Lord be done” (21:14).
3. “Men of Israel, help! This is the man who is teaching everyone everywhere against the people and the law and this place” (21:28).
4. “I am a Jew, from Tarsus in Cilicia, a citizen of no obscure city” (21:39).
5. “Brought up in this city, educated at the feet of Gamaliel according to the strict manner of the law of our fathers, being zealous for God as all of you are this day” (22:3).

6. “And I answered, Who are you, Lord? And he said to me, I am Jesus of Nazareth, whom you are persecuting” (22:8).
7. “And now why do you wait? Rise and be baptized and wash away your sins, calling on his name” (22:16).
8. “Go, for I will send you far away to the Gentiles” (22:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

On the way, Paul and his companions stop in Tyre, where disciples urge him through the Spirit not to go to Jerusalem. In Caesarea, the prophet Agabus takes Paul’s belt, binds his own hands and feet, and says that the Jews at Jerusalem will bind the man who owns this belt. His friends beg him not to go. Paul replies with a moving statement: “What are you doing, weeping and breaking my heart? For I am ready not only to be imprisoned but even to die at Jerusalem for the name of the Lord Jesus.” When he would not be dissuaded, they said, “Let the will of the Lord be done.” He is not reckless. He is obedient.

In Jerusalem, James and the elders rejoice at the reports of the Gentiles. But they tell Paul that thousands of Jewish believers are zealous for the law and have heard that he teaches Jews to forsake Moses. They suggest he pay the expenses of four men under a vow. Paul agrees, an example of his flexibility (1 Corinthians 9:20). But Jews from Asia see him in the temple, seize him, and cry out that he has brought Greeks into the temple and defiled it. The whole city is stirred up. They drag him out and beat him, and he is rescued by the Roman tribune and his soldiers, who bind him with two chains.

As he is carried up the steps, Paul asks the tribune, in Greek, for permission to speak. The tribune is surprised. Paul addresses the crowd in Aramaic. He tells his story: a Jew born in Tarsus, trained under Gamaliel, zealous for God, who persecuted the Way to the death. On the Damascus road, he met the risen Jesus. Ananias said: “The God of our fathers appointed you to know his will, to see the Righteous One and to hear a voice from his mouth; for you will be a witness for him to everyone of what you have seen and heard. And now why do you wait? Rise and be baptized and wash your sins away, calling on his name.” Then Paul tells of a vision in the temple, where Jesus said, “Go, for I will send you far away to the Gentiles.”

At the word “Gentiles,” the crowd erupts, shouting, “Away with such a fellow from the earth!” The tribune orders him brought into the barracks to be examined by flogging. Paul asks the centurion, “Is it lawful for you to flog a man who is a Roman citizen and uncondemned?” The tribune becomes afraid. The next day he brings Paul before the council. Once again, Paul’s Roman citizenship protects him.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 9:1-19 and 26:9-18 are the other accounts of his conversion. Galatians 1:13-16 gives his own testimony. Philippians 3:4-11 lists his Jewish credentials and counts them as loss. 1 Corinthians 9:19-23 describes his adaptability. Luke 9:51 shows Jesus setting his face toward Jerusalem. Romans 15:25-31 is Paul's request for prayer about the trip. 2 Corinthians 11:23-28 lists his sufferings. Matthew 26:39 is Jesus' prayer, "Not as I will, but as you will."

STEP 6

Application

Practice telling your own story of how you met Jesus in two minutes.

Ask whether there is a step of obedience you have avoided because of fear.

Pray "Let the will of the Lord be done" for a situation you cannot control.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to give you courage to obey even when it costs you.

Thank Jesus for setting his face toward Jerusalem.

Ask him to make you a witness in your setting.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 103

"But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God."

ACTS 20:24

DAY 720 · WEEK 103

Acts 23:1-24:27

Before the Sanhedrin and Felix

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 23:1-24:27. Paul appears before the Sanhedrin, the Lord encourages him, a plot is foiled, and he is brought to Caesarea to stand before Governor Felix. Notice Paul's conscience and the center of his defense: the resurrection.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul is in Roman custody, and the tribune brings him before the Jewish council to find out what he is accused of. Here and in the following hearings, Paul consistently turns the discussion to the hope of the resurrection. A plot of more than forty men to kill him is uncovered by his nephew, and he is moved by night to Caesarea, the Roman capital, where he is held under Governor Felix for two years.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Brothers, I have lived my life before God in all good conscience up to this day" (23:1).
2. "Brothers, I am a Pharisee, a son of Pharisees. It is with respect to the hope and the resurrection of the dead that I am on trial" (23:6).
3. "The following night the Lord stood by him and said, Take courage, for as you have testified to the facts about me in Jerusalem, so you must testify also in Rome" (23:11).
4. "According to the Way, which they call a sect, I worship the God of our fathers, believing everything that is laid down by the Law and written in the Prophets" (24:14).
5. "Having a hope in God, which these men themselves accept, that there will be a resurrection of both the just and the unjust" (24:15).
6. "So I always take pains to have a clear conscience toward both God and man" (24:16).

7. “And as he reasoned about righteousness and self-control and future judgment, Felix was alarmed and said, Go away for the present. When I get an opportunity I will summon you” (24:25).

8. “Felix left Paul in prison” (24:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Before the council, Paul begins, “Brothers, I have lived my life before God in all good conscience up to this day.” The high priest Ananias orders him struck on the mouth. Paul says, “God is going to strike you, you whitewashed wall!” When told that he is speaking to the high priest, Paul apologizes, acknowledging the law: “You shall not speak evil of a ruler of your people.” Even apostles had sharp moments.

Then Paul realizes the council is divided between Sadducees and Pharisees. He cries out, “Brothers, I am a Pharisee, a son of Pharisees. It is with respect to the hope and the resurrection of the dead that I am on trial.” The council erupts in dispute. Some argue that they find nothing wrong with the man. The tribune, fearing Paul will be torn to pieces, takes him back to the barracks. That night, “the Lord stood by him and said, Take courage, for as you have testified to the facts about me in Jerusalem, so you must testify also in Rome.” This is a vital promise. Whatever happens, Paul will reach Rome.

A plot is hatched: more than forty men take an oath neither to eat nor drink until they have killed Paul. Paul’s nephew hears of it and warns the tribune, who sends Paul under heavy guard (two hundred soldiers, seventy horsemen, two hundred spearmen) to Governor Felix in Caesarea. God uses the Roman army to protect his apostle.

Five days later, the high priest and a lawyer named Tertullus arrive and accuse Paul. Paul’s defense is calm and clear. He had not stirred up a crowd; he came to Jerusalem to bring alms. “According to the Way, which they call a sect, I worship the God of our fathers, believing everything that is laid down by the Law and written in the Prophets.” The Christian faith is not a new religion but the fulfillment of Israel’s hope. His hope is the resurrection of both the just and the unjust. “So I always take pains to have a clear conscience toward both God and man.”

Felix, who knows more about the Way than most, puts off a decision. Later, he and his wife Drusilla hear Paul speak about faith in Christ Jesus. As Paul reasons about righteousness, self-control, and future judgment, Felix becomes alarmed and sends him away. He hopes for a bribe and sends for Paul often, but nothing changes. After two years, Felix is succeeded by Festus, and desiring to do the Jews a favor, he leaves Paul in prison. Felix is a warning: he heard the truth, was alarmed, and put it off.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 22:28 is the law Paul cites about speaking evil of rulers. Daniel 12:2 speaks of the resurrection of the just and the unjust. Luke 20:27-38 records Jesus on the resurrection against the Sadducees. Acts 4:1-2 and 17:32 show the resurrection as a point of dispute. 1 Corinthians 15 is Paul's great chapter on the resurrection. 2 Corinthians 1:12 mentions a clear conscience. 1 Timothy 1:5 and 1:19 speak of a good conscience. Proverbs 27:1 warns against boasting about tomorrow. Hebrews 3:15 says today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your conscience is clear before God and man. If not, confess and make it right.

Do you put off a conviction because the timing is not convenient? Respond today.

Take courage from the Lord's word to Paul. He stands by you too.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for standing by Paul, and ask him to stand by you.
- Ask him for a clear conscience before him.
- Tell him what you fear.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 103

"But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God."

ACTS 20:24

DAY 721 · WEEK 103

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Acts 20:24 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God."

ACTS 20:24

REST

Meditation

Paul says this to the Ephesian elders on the beach at Miletus, knowing that he is going to Jerusalem and that chains and afflictions await.

"I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself." Paul is not careless about his life. He knows its worth, but he does not hold it as the highest good. For him, life is a trust, to be spent for something greater.

"If only I may finish my course." He pictures his life as a race to finish. A course has a beginning and an end, and the goal is to complete it. In his last letter, Paul writes that he has fought the good fight, finished the race, and kept the faith.

"And the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus." The task is not Paul's invention. It is received, given by the Lord Jesus himself. Each of us also receives a calling.

“To testify to the gospel of the grace of God.” This is the center of Paul’s ministry. Not his own cleverness, but the good news of grace: that sinners are saved freely by God’s favor in Christ.

When you are afraid of the cost of faithfulness, say this verse. The goal is not to protect our lives but to finish the course and testify to the grace of God.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw Paul on the road: a full Jerusalem Council behind him and the ministry in Ephesus finished. You read his tender farewell to the Ephesian elders, with its charge to shepherd the church of God, which he obtained with his own blood. Three psalms sang the mission: Psalm 96, declare his glory among the nations; Psalm 98, all the ends of the earth have seen the salvation of our God; and Psalm 100, enter his gates with thanksgiving. Then Paul went up to Jerusalem, knowing what awaited him. You watched him seized in the temple, retell his conversion on the steps, stand before the council and Felix, and speak of the hope of the resurrection. The Lord told him, “Take courage… you must testify also in Rome.”

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul said he did not count his life as precious if only he could finish his course. What is one thing in your life that you are holding too tightly, and what would it look like to hold it more loosely for the sake of Christ?

Paul told the elders to care for the church “which he obtained with his own blood.” How does that change the way you think about your own church and its people?

Felix heard the truth, was alarmed, and put it off. Is there a truth God is pressing on you that you’ve been postponing? What is one step you can take today?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for the church he bought with his blood.

Ask him to help you finish your course.

Rest in him.

DAY 722 · WEEK 104

Acts 25:1-26:32

Before Festus and Agrippa, "I stand on trial for hope"

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 25:1-26:32. Paul appeals to Caesar, and then makes his defense before King Agrippa. His third account of his conversion ends with an appeal. Read 26:12-29 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Felix is succeeded by Festus, who immediately faces the Jewish leaders' demand to bring Paul to Jerusalem, where they plan an ambush. Paul, as a Roman citizen, exercises his right to appeal to Caesar. Before sending him to Rome, Festus consults King Agrippa II, who is familiar with Jewish customs. The hearing is an opportunity for Paul to give a full account of the gospel before the political and military leaders of the region.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I appeal to Caesar" (25:11).
2. "And now I stand here on trial because of my hope in the promise made by God to our fathers" (26:6).
3. "Why is it thought incredible by any of you that God raises the dead?" (26:8).
4. "To open their eyes, so that they may turn from darkness to light and from the power of Satan to God, that they may receive forgiveness of sins and a place among those who are sanctified by faith in me" (26:18).
5. "Therefore, O King Agrippa, I was not disobedient to the vision from heaven" (26:19).
6. "To this day I have had the help that comes from God, and so I stand here testifying both to small and great, saying nothing but what the prophets and Moses said would come to pass" (26:22).

7. “In a short time would you persuade me to be a Christian?” (26:28).

8. “Whether short or long, I would to God that not only you but also all who hear me this day might become such as I am, except for these chains” (26:29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Festus tells the Jews that Roman custom does not condemn a man before he has met his accusers face to face. At Caesarea, they bring many serious charges that they cannot prove. Festus, wishing to do the Jews a favor, asks Paul whether he is willing to go to Jerusalem for trial. Paul knows what would happen. “I appeal to Caesar.” This appeal, within a Roman citizen’s rights, takes the case to Rome and fulfills the Lord’s promise in 23:11.

When King Agrippa and his sister Bernice arrive, Festus explains his dilemma: he has no clear charge to write to the emperor. Agrippa asks to hear Paul. Paul says he considers himself fortunate to defend himself before one so familiar with Jewish customs. He tells his story: his strict Pharisaic upbringing, his persecution of the saints, and his encounter on the Damascus road. He now reports the commission with its fullest wording. Jesus said he was sending Paul “to open their eyes, so that they may turn from darkness to light and from the power of Satan to God, that they may receive forgiveness of sins and a place among those who are sanctified by faith in me.” This is a summary of the gospel: darkness to light, Satan’s power to God, forgiveness and an inheritance, by faith in Christ.

Paul says, “I was not disobedient to the vision from heaven.” He declared to Jews and Gentiles that they should repent and turn to God, performing deeds in keeping with their repentance. For this, the Jews seized him. And yet he says, “I stand here testifying both to small and great, saying nothing but what the prophets and Moses said would come to pass: that the Christ must suffer and, by being the first to rise from the dead, would proclaim light both to our people and to the Gentiles.”

Festus interrupts: “Paul, you are out of your mind; your great learning is driving you out of your mind.” Paul replies, “I am not out of my mind, most excellent Festus, but I am speaking the sober truth.” Then he turns to Agrippa: “King Agrippa, do you believe the prophets? I know that you believe.” Agrippa says, “In a short time would you persuade me to be a Christian?” Paul’s reply is full of grace: “Whether short or long, I would to God that not only you but also all who hear me this day might become such as I am, except for these chains.” Agrippa concludes that Paul could have been set free if he had not appealed to Caesar. But the appeal is God’s means of bringing him to Rome.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 9:1-19 and 22:1-21 are the other accounts of the conversion. Isaiah 42:6-7 and 49:6 speak of opening blind eyes and being a light to the Gentiles. Isaiah 53 and Psalm 22 speak of the Christ's suffering. 1 Corinthians 15:3-8 summarizes the gospel as Paul received it. Colossians 1:12-14 echoes the language of 26:18. 2 Timothy 4:16-18 mentions the Lord standing by him at his first defense. Philippians 1:12-14 says his imprisonment advanced the gospel. Romans 13:1-7 teaches about the state.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Acts 26:18 as a summary of what conversion means.

Ask yourself Paul's question to Agrippa: do you believe the prophets?

Think of someone who is "almost persuaded." Pray for them as Paul did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for opening your eyes and turning you from darkness to light.
- Ask him to give you a clear testimony.
- Pray for someone who is hardened against him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 104

"For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek."

ROMANS 1:16

DAY 723 · WEEK 104

Acts 27:1-28:31

The voyage; the shipwreck; Rome

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 27:1-28:31. Paul sails for Rome, endures a storm and a shipwreck, survives a snakebite on Malta, and arrives in the capital. The book ends with Paul under house arrest, preaching the kingdom of God. Notice how Acts ends: without a conclusion, because the story continues.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul is sent to Rome as a prisoner under the centurion Julius, along with Luke and Aristarchus. It is late in the sailing season and dangerous. Luke's account of the voyage is among the most detailed ancient descriptions of a sea journey. Beyond its drama, the voyage shows God's faithfulness in carrying out the promise made in 23:11: Paul will testify in Rome.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When neither sun nor stars appeared for many days, and no small tempest lay on us, all hope of our being saved was at last abandoned" (27:20).
2. "Do not be afraid, Paul; you must stand before Caesar" (27:24).
3. "So take heart, men, for I have faith in God that it will be exactly as I have been told" (27:25).
4. "And so it was that all were brought safely to land" (27:44).
5. "And the brothers there, when they heard about us, came as far as the Forum of Appius and Three Taverns to meet us. On seeing them, Paul thanked God and took courage" (28:15).

6. “From morning till evening he expounded to them, testifying to the kingdom of God and trying to convince them about Jesus both from the Law of Moses and from the Prophets” (28:23).

7. “Therefore let it be known to you that this salvation of God has been sent to the Gentiles; they will listen” (28:28).

8. “Proclaiming the kingdom of God and teaching about the Lord Jesus Christ with all boldness and without hindrance” (28:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The voyage begins in good weather but deteriorates. Paul warns that the journey will be dangerous, but the centurion trusts the pilot and the owner of the ship. A violent northeaster, the “Euraquilo,” seizes the ship. For days they are driven, throwing cargo and tackle overboard. “All hope of our being saved was at last abandoned.” Then Paul stands up: an angel of God had stood by him that night and said, “Do not be afraid, Paul; you must stand before Caesar. And behold, God has granted you all those who sail with you.” “So take heart, men, for I have faith in God that it will be exactly as I have been told.” The prisoner becomes the leader of the ship. When sailors try to escape in the lifeboat, Paul warns the centurion. On the fourteenth night, Paul urges them all to eat, takes bread, gives thanks to God in the presence of all, and breaks it. Two hundred seventy-six people are on board. The ship runs aground, and the soldiers plan to kill the prisoners, but the centurion, wishing to save Paul, stops them. All reach land safely, some swimming and some on pieces of the ship.

On Malta, the islanders show unusual kindness. A viper fastens on Paul’s hand, and the people expect him to die; when he shakes it off and suffers no harm, they say he is a god. This is a reversal of Lystra, where they first worshiped and then stoned him. Paul heals the father of the chief man of the island, and the rest of the sick come and are cured. After three months, they sail again for Rome.

Believers meet Paul at the Forum of Appius and Three Taverns, “and on seeing them, Paul thanked God and took courage.” In Rome, he is allowed to live by himself with a soldier guarding him. Three days later, he calls the local Jewish leaders and explains why he is in chains: “it is because of the hope of Israel.” They arrange a day, and many come to his lodging. “From morning till evening he expounded to them, testifying to the kingdom of God and trying to convince them about Jesus both from the Law of Moses and from the Prophets.” Some are convinced, others disbelieve. Paul quotes Isaiah 6 about hardened hearts and says, “This salvation of God has been sent to the Gentiles; they will listen.”

The book ends abruptly: “He lived there two whole years at his own expense, and welcomed all who came to him, proclaiming the kingdom of God and teaching about the Lord Jesus Christ with all boldness and without hindrance.” Luke does not tell us what happened to Paul at the trial. The ending is deliberate: the word of God is not bound (2 Timothy 2:9). The story of the church continues in every generation, including yours. From Jerusalem to Rome, from the upper room to the center of the empire, the gospel has gone out.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 1:8 is the program that is fulfilled here. Psalm 107:23-30 describes sailors rescued from a storm. Jonah 1 is another storm at sea. Isaiah 6:9-10 is the quotation about hardened hearts. Romans 1:8-15 and 15:22-29 reveal Paul’s longing to see Rome. Philippians 1:12-14, Ephesians 6:19-20, Colossians 4:3, and Philemon are letters from this imprisonment. 2 Timothy 4:6-8 is his final testimony. Ephesians 2:19-22 describes the household of God.

STEP 6

Application

Review your own storms. Was God keeping a promise that you couldn’t see?

Read Acts 1:8 again and see how the book has fulfilled it. Where are you in the story?

Take the closing words as a charge: proclaim the kingdom and teach about Jesus with all boldness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the book of Acts and the word spreading to the ends of the earth.
- Thank him for his faithfulness through storms.
- Ask him to keep you bold and unhindered.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 104

“For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek.”

ROMANS 1:16

DAY 724 · WEEK 104

Review and Reflection

Unit 19 review, The New Covenant Applied, Acts

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."
>
> ACTS 1:8

REST

Meditation

Jesus speaks these words to his disciples just before he ascends. They are his last words in Acts, and they set the agenda for the rest of the book and the church age.

"But you will receive power." Jesus does not ask the disciples to do the work in their own strength. They will receive power. The power is not for show, but for witness.

"When the Holy Spirit has come upon you." The source of the power is the Holy Spirit, poured out at Pentecost. Without him there is no true witness. With him, ordinary people become bold.

"And you will be my witnesses." A witness tells what he has seen and heard. The disciples had seen the risen Jesus. We have the testimony of Scripture and our own experience of grace. We too can tell what we know.

"In Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria." The witness begins at home, in your city, then reaches the surrounding region and the despised outsiders. Each of us has a Jerusalem, a Judea, and a Samaria.

"And to the end of the earth." There is no limit. The gospel is for every nation, and the church is called to carry it there.

When you feel inadequate to share the gospel, say this verse. The power is his, and the promise is for you.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

You have read the book of Acts, the story of the risen Christ continuing his work by the Holy Spirit through his church. It began with the ascension, when Jesus promised power to witness in Jerusalem, Judea, Samaria, and the ends of the earth. In four doctrinal pauses, you studied Christ's ascension and reign, the person and work of the Holy Spirit, repentance, and the means of grace. At Pentecost, the Spirit was poured out on all flesh, fulfilling Joel, Ezekiel, and Jeremiah, and Peter preached that God had made Jesus both Lord and Christ. The church devoted itself to the apostles' teaching, fellowship, the breaking of bread, and prayer. Despite arrests, the death of Stephen, and persecution, the word of God increased. It moved to Samaria, to an Ethiopian official, and to Cornelius, the first Gentile convert, when God showed Peter that no one is common or unclean. Saul, the persecutor, met the risen Christ and became Paul, the apostle to the Gentiles. The church at Antioch sent Barnabas and Paul on the first journey, the Jerusalem Council affirmed that Gentiles are saved by grace through faith, and the second and third journeys planted churches in Philippi, Thessalonica, Athens, Corinth, and Ephesus, in line with the Abrahamic promise that all families of the earth would be blessed. Paul's farewell to the Ephesian elders charged them to shepherd the church of God, and he went up to Jerusalem, was arrested, defended himself before Felix, Festus, and Agrippa, and was brought through storm and shipwreck to Rome, where he preached the kingdom of God with all boldness and without hindrance. The Psalms accompanied the story: Psalms 2, 16, and 110 for the exalted Christ, and Psalms 67, 87, 117, 96, 98, and 100 for the nations.

REFLECT

Review Questions

How does Pentecost fulfill the promises of Joel, Ezekiel, and Jeremiah?

Read Joel 2:28-32, Ezekiel 36:26-27, Jeremiah 31:33-34, and Acts 2:14-21. What did these prophets promise about the Spirit and the new covenant, and what do you see in Acts 2 that matches?

What does the Jerusalem Council decide?

Reread Acts 15:1-35. What was the question, how did Peter and James reason, and what was the result? Why does this matter for the gospel of grace?

How does Paul's missionary strategy reflect the Abrahamic promise?

Think about Genesis 12:3 and Acts 13:47. Notice where Paul went first, how the Gentiles responded, and how he planted churches with elders. How does this show that the promise to bless all nations was being fulfilled?

What does Acts teach us about the nature of the church?

Look at Acts 2:42-47 and 20:28. What are the marks of a healthy church? What does it mean that the church belongs to God, who obtained it with his own blood?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the Spirit who empowers witnesses.

Thank him for how the gospel has reached you.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 20 · DAYS 725-752

The New Covenant Explained: Romans

Romans 1-16

The righteousness of God revealed. Justification, sanctification, and God's purposes in history.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 8:1

Psalms 32, 143, 19, and 117, which Paul quotes in Romans, with 130 and 116.

UNIT 20

In this unit

WEEK 104

725	Romans 1:1-32	*Reading*
726	Romans 1:18-32; Nahum 1:2-8	*Doctrine*
727	Romans 2:1-29	*Reading*
728	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 105

729	Romans 3:1-31	*Reading*
730	Romans 3:21-31; Romans 4:1-8; Galatians 2:15-21	*Doctrine*
731	Romans 4:1-25	*Reading*
732	Psalm 32	*Psalm*
733	Psalm 130	*Psalm*
734	Psalm 143:1-12	*Psalm*
735	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 106

736	Romans 5:1-21	*Reading*
737	Romans 6:1-14; Galatians 2:20; Ephesians 2:4-10	*Doctrine*
738	Romans 6:1-23	*Reading*
739	Romans 7:1-25	*Reading*
740	Romans 6:1-14; 1 Thessalonians 4:1-8; Philippians 2:12-13	*Doctrine*
741	Romans 8:1-39	*Reading*
742	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 107

743	Romans 9:1-33	*Reading*
744	Romans 10:1-11:36	*Reading*
745	Psalm 19:1-6	*Psalm*
746	Psalm 116	*Psalm*

747	Psalm 117	*Psalm*
748	Romans 12:1-13:14	*Reading*
749	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 108

750	Romans 14:1-15:13	*Reading*
751	Romans 15:14-16:27	*Reading*
752	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 725 · WEEK 104

Romans 1:1-32

The gospel; the righteousness of God; the wrath of God

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 1:1-32. This is the opening of Paul's greatest letter. Read the greeting (1:1-7), then the theme statement (1:16-17), and then the dark diagnosis of the human race (1:18-32). Ask what makes the gospel good news, and why it must begin with bad news.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul writes to the church in Rome from Corinth, around AD 57, at the end of his third missionary journey. He has never been to Rome, but he hopes to visit on his way to Spain. The church is made up of Jewish and Gentile believers who have tensions between them. Paul writes the fullest explanation of the gospel found anywhere in Scripture: how sinners are made right with a holy God, how they are changed, and how God's promises to Israel and the nations fit together. Romans is the great explanation of the new covenant. The Reformation was lit by it, and countless believers have been converted while reading it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Paul, a servant of Christ Jesus, called to be an apostle, set apart for the gospel of God" (1:1).
2. "And was declared to be the Son of God in power according to the Spirit of holiness by his resurrection from the dead, Jesus Christ our Lord" (1:4).
3. "For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek" (1:16).
4. "For in it the righteousness of God is revealed from faith for faith, as it is written, The righteous shall live by faith" (1:17).

5. “For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men, who by their unrighteousness suppress the truth” (1:18).

6. “For his invisible attributes, namely, his eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly perceived, ever since the creation of the world, in the things that have been made” (1:20).

7. “For although they knew God, they did not honor him as God or give thanks to him” (1:21).

8. “Because they exchanged the truth about God for a lie and worshiped and served the creature rather than the Creator, who is blessed forever! Amen” (1:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul introduces himself as a servant, literally a slave, of Christ Jesus, an apostle, set apart for the gospel of God. He immediately says that this gospel was promised beforehand through the prophets in the holy Scriptures. The good news is not new. It is the fulfillment of the Old Testament. Its subject is God’s Son, descended from David according to the flesh and declared to be the Son of God in power by his resurrection from the dead. Through him, Paul has received grace and apostleship “to bring about the obedience of faith for the sake of his name among all the nations.” He writes to Romans who are “called to be saints.” Every Christian is a saint, a holy one set apart by God.

Paul longs to see them, to impart some spiritual gift, and to be mutually encouraged. Then he gives the thesis of the whole letter: “I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek.” The gospel is not advice; it is power. It saves. And it saves “everyone who believes,” on one condition. Verse 17 states the heart: “In it the righteousness of God is revealed from faith for faith, as it is written, The righteous shall live by faith.” This is a quotation of Habakkuk 2:4. The righteousness of God here is God’s saving action and the gift of righteous standing that he gives. Martin Luther said that when he understood this phrase he felt he had entered paradise through open gates.

But why do we need the gospel? Paul now tells the bad news. “The wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men, who by their unrighteousness suppress the truth.” People know God from creation: his eternal power and divine nature are clearly perceived in the things he has made. So no one has an excuse. The problem is not lack of information but suppression of it. They knew God, but they did not honor him as God or give thanks. Their thinking became futile, their hearts darkened. Claiming to be wise, they became fools, exchanging the glory of the immortal God for images. Three times, Paul says, “God gave them up”: to impurity, to dishonorable passions, to

a debased mind. God's judgment here takes the form of letting sin run its course. The chapter ends with a long list of sins and the sober note that they not only do these things but give approval to those who practice them.

This is hard reading. But it prepares the way. A doctor who diagnoses cancer gently cannot be trusted. Paul tells the truth so that the good news may be heard as good.

STEP 5

Connection

Habakkuk 2:4 is the source of 1:17. Psalm 19:1-4 declares that the heavens proclaim God's glory. Genesis 1 to 3 is the background for the fall in 1:21-25. Acts 14:15-17 and 17:22-31 show Paul preaching the same truth about creation. Jeremiah 2:11-13 describes exchanging glory for what cannot profit. Ephesians 4:17-19 describes darkened understanding. 1 Corinthians 1:18-25 speaks of the power of the cross. Romans 3:21 to 5:21 will answer the problem posed here.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Romans 1:16 and ask whether you are ashamed of the gospel in any setting. Where are you tempted to stay silent?

Ask what you honor above God or give thanks for in a way that forgets the Giver.

Thank God that he does not leave us at the end of Romans 1.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the gospel, the power for salvation.

Ask him to keep you from shame in it.

Thank him that the righteous shall live by faith.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 104

"For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek."

ROMANS 1:16

DAY 726 · WEEK 104

Romans 1:18-32; Nahum 1:2-8

Divine opposition to sin

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Doctrine · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 1:18-32 again, and then Nahum 1:2-8. Today is a doctrinal pause on the wrath of God. The question is simple and hard: how can a God of love be angry? Read slowly, and notice that Nahum holds wrath and goodness together in the same breath.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Many people are uneasy with the idea that God is angry. Some picture the God of the Old Testament as wrathful and the God of the New as gentle, but the New Testament speaks of wrath at least as often as the Old. Paul says it is the first thing "revealed" in the gospel's unfolding (Romans 1:18). The prophet Nahum, writing perhaps a century after Jonah, announces judgment on Nineveh, the same city that repented under Jonah and later returned to cruelty. Together the two passages give us a biblical view of divine opposition to sin.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men" (Romans 1:18).
2. "Therefore God gave them up in the lusts of their hearts to impurity" (Romans 1:24).
3. "For this reason God gave them up to dishonorable passions" (Romans 1:26).
4. "God gave them up to a debased mind to do what ought not to be done" (Romans 1:28).
5. "The LORD is a jealous and avenging God; the LORD is avenging and wrathful" (Nahum 1:2).

6. “The LORD is slow to anger and great in power, and the LORD will by no means clear the guilty” (Nahum 1:3).

7. “Who can stand before his indignation? Who can endure the heat of his anger?” (Nahum 1:6).

8. “The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble; he knows those who take refuge in him” (Nahum 1:7).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The wrath of God is his settled, holy, and righteous opposition to all evil. It is not a loss of temper. Human anger is often selfish, sudden, and out of control. God’s wrath is none of these. It flows from his holiness and his love of what is good. A God who did not hate injustice, cruelty, and the destruction of his creatures would not be good. If we love victims, we should want a God who is angry at what harms them.

Scripture describes wrath in at least two ways. In Romans 1, wrath is revealed in the present, as God gives people over to the consequences of their own choices: sin becomes its own punishment. And elsewhere wrath is future: Paul speaks of a “day of wrath when God’s righteous judgment will be revealed” (Romans 2:5). Nahum shows God’s wrath as both patient and certain: “slow to anger,” yet he “will by no means clear the guilty.”

The wrath of God is the background that makes the gospel good news. At the cross, Jesus bore this wrath for his people. The word “propitiation” (Romans 3:25) means a sacrifice that turns away wrath. Christians have debated the word, but its main meaning is clear: God’s justice and God’s love meet at the cross, where the Son absorbs what sin deserves. Therefore, for the believer, “there is now no condemnation” (Romans 8:1). Nahum 1:7 is the comfort: “The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble; he knows those who take refuge in him.” The same God who is a fire to his enemies is a refuge to those who run to him. Christians differ on how to describe the final punishment of the unrepentant, but all agree that God’s judgment is just.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul says wrath “is revealed from heaven.” It is not a mere theory; it is evident in the moral order of the world. Then he describes its form three times: “God gave them up.” Notice the pattern. People suppress the truth, and God gives them up to impurity (verse 24). They exchange the truth about God for a lie, and God gives them up to dishonorable passions (verse 26). They do not see fit to acknowledge God, and God gives them up to a debased mind

(verse 28). The result is a downward spiral. Sin is not merely breaking rules; it is worship turned the wrong way. When we will not worship the Creator, we worship the creature, and the creature cannot bear the weight.

Nahum brings the other side of the picture. The prophet opens with a hymn to the character of God. “The LORD is a jealous and avenging God.” Jealous here means that he will not share his glory or his people with idols, as a husband is rightly jealous for his wife. “Slow to anger and great in power,” a phrase that echoes Exodus 34:6-7. Slow to anger means patience, not weakness. Nineveh had been given time and a prophet. But patience has an end. Mountains quake before him, and the earth heaves. “Who can stand before his indignation?”

Then, in the middle of the storm, the verse that changes the tone: “The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble; he knows those who take refuge in him.” There are only two kinds of people before this God: those who stand against him and those who take refuge in him. The gospel is the invitation to refuge. Jesus is the place where the storm has already broken. Wrath fell on him at Calvary so that it would not fall on us.

When we say we are unsettled by the wrath of God, we do well to ask what it would mean for him not to be angry at evil. Paul teaches that the cure for our unease is not to quiet the doctrine but to run to the cross.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 34:6-7 describes the character of God with mercy and justice. Psalm 7:11 says God is angry with the wicked every day. John 3:36 speaks of the wrath of God remaining on those who do not believe. Romans 2:5, 5:9, and 1 Thessalonians 1:10 speak of wrath to come and our deliverance. Romans 3:25 and 1 John 4:10 speak of propitiation. Hebrews 12:28-29 says our God is a consuming fire. Jonah 3 to 4 is the earlier chapter of Nineveh’s story. Revelation 6:15-17 describes the wrath of the Lamb.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you have been tempted to soften what Scripture says about God’s wrath, and why.

If you are afraid of God’s judgment, take refuge in Christ today. Say the words of Nahum 1:7 as a prayer.

Pray for someone you love who does not yet see their need of a Savior.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have wanted a God without wrath.
- Ask him to teach you to see his wrath and his mercy together.
- Thank Jesus for bearing wrath for you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 104

"For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek."

ROMANS 1:16

DAY 727 · WEEK 104

Romans 2:1-29

God's righteous judgment; circumcision of the heart

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 29 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 2:1-29. Paul turns from the obvious sinners to the religious and moral person. Notice the standard of God's judgment, and what Paul means by a Jew "inwardly."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the dark picture in chapter 1, a Jewish reader might say, "Yes, those pagans deserve it!" Paul now closes the trap. In the style of a diatribe, a lively argument with an imaginary opponent, he shows that the moral person and the religious person are also under judgment. Having the Law, being circumcised, and belonging to the covenant people are not a shelter from God's verdict. Paul's point is that every mouth must be stopped (3:19).

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Therefore you have no excuse, O man, every one of you who judges. For in passing judgment on another you condemn yourself, because you, the judge, practice the very same things" (2:1).
2. "Or do you presume on the riches of his kindness and forbearance and patience, not knowing that God's kindness is meant to lead you to repentance?" (2:4).
3. "He will render to each one according to his works" (2:6).
4. "For God shows no partiality" (2:11).
5. "For it is not the hearers of the law who are righteous before God, but the doers of the law who will be justified" (2:13).

6. “They show that the work of the law is written on their hearts, while their conscience also bears witness” (2:15).

7. “On that day when, according to my gospel, God judges the secrets of men by Christ Jesus” (2:16).

8. “But a Jew is one inwardly, and circumcision is a matter of the heart, by the Spirit, not by the letter” (2:29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with the person who judges others: “You have no excuse.” Those who condemn others for the same sins they commit prove that they know right from wrong and fail to keep it. God’s judgment is according to truth. Then comes a lovely question: “Do you presume on the riches of his kindness and forbearance and patience, not knowing that God’s kindness is meant to lead you to repentance?” God’s patience is not approval. It is a window of mercy. To ignore it is to store up wrath for the day of wrath.

God will “render to each one according to his works.” This sentence raises a question that students of Romans have asked for centuries: does Paul teach salvation by works? No. He is describing the standard of the final judgment. God will judge impartially, by works, because works reveal the heart. Eternal life goes to those who by patience in doing good seek glory and honor and immortality; wrath to those who are self-seeking and do not obey the truth. But Paul will go on to show that no one meets this standard (3:9-20), and the believer’s works are the fruit and evidence of faith, not its foundation. The judgment according to works does not contradict justification by faith. It shows that real faith produces a changed life.

Paul next addresses the Jew who relies on the Law and boasts in God. He asks four hard questions: you teach others, do you teach yourself? You say not to steal, do you steal? Do you commit adultery? Do you rob temples? “The name of God is blasphemed among the Gentiles because of you,” he writes, quoting Isaiah 52:5. Circumcision has value if you keep the law, but if you break it, your circumcision becomes uncircumcision. And an uncircumcised man who keeps the law’s requirements will be counted as circumcised.

The chapter closes with the center of the new covenant: “A Jew is one inwardly, and circumcision is a matter of the heart, by the Spirit, not by the letter.” This echoes Deuteronomy 30:6 and Jeremiah 31:33. The true people of God are those whose hearts the Spirit has changed. Outward signs without inward reality count for nothing. This is a key text for progressive covenantalism: the promises made to Israel find their fulfillment in a people marked by the Spirit, Jew and Gentile together in Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 10:16 and 30:6 call for circumcision of the heart. Jeremiah 9:25-26 and 31:31-34 speak of the heart and the new covenant. Ezekiel 36:26-27 promises the Spirit. Matthew 7:1-5 is Jesus on judging. Matthew 23 condemns hypocrisy. Ecclesiastes 12:14 says God will bring every deed into judgment. 2 Corinthians 5:10 says we must appear before the judgment seat of Christ. Philippians 3:3 says we are the circumcision, who worship by the Spirit of God. Galatians 6:15 says neither circumcision nor uncircumcision counts for anything, but a new creation.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you judge others for what you do yourself. Confess it.

Think of a time when God's kindness led you to repentance. Thank him for it.

Examine whether your faith is outward or has reached the heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you judge others and excuse yourself.
- Ask him to circumcise your heart.
- Thank him for his kindness that leads you to repentance.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 104

"For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek."

ROMANS 1:16

DAY 728 · WEEK 104

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Romans 1:16 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek."

ROMANS 1:16

REST

Meditation

Paul writes this verse at the start of the greatest explanation of the gospel ever written.

"I am not ashamed of the gospel." Paul says this because the gospel is easy to be ashamed of. It speaks of a crucified Savior, which seemed foolish to Greeks and offensive to Jews. It tells us we are sinners who cannot save ourselves. The world's wisdom has not changed. And yet Paul is not ashamed. His boldness does not come from temperament but from conviction.

"For it is the power of God for salvation." The gospel is not only information or a good idea. It is the power of God, the means by which he saves. When it is preached, God works. Dead hearts are raised, and enemies become children.

"To everyone who believes." The gospel has a condition that is not a work: believing. It rests on Christ and not on us. It is open to all.

“To the Jew first and also to the Greek.” The gospel came to Israel first, and the promises were theirs. But it goes beyond to every nation. In Romans, Paul will show how Jew and Gentile are saved the same way.

When you are tempted to be quiet about your faith, say this verse. The power does not rest in your ability to explain, but in the gospel itself.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began Paul’s letter to the Romans, the great explanation of the new covenant. You read the opening greeting and the statement of the theme: the gospel is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, and in it the righteousness of God is revealed from faith for faith. Then Paul gave the bad news that makes the good news necessary. God’s wrath is revealed against all who suppress the truth, and he gives them up to the consequences of their sin. In a doctrinal pause, you thought about the wrath of God as his holy opposition to evil, and with Nahum you saw that the same God is a stronghold to those who take refuge in him. In chapter 2, Paul turned to the moral and religious person: God judges impartially, his kindness is meant to lead to repentance, and a true Jew is one inwardly, circumcised in heart by the Spirit.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says he is not ashamed of the gospel. In what setting, with which people, are you most tempted to be ashamed or silent about Christ? What would it look like to speak with quiet confidence there?

Romans 1 and 2 show that everyone, religious or not, is guilty before God. How does the cross of Jesus, where he bore the wrath we deserved, change the way you feel when you read these chapters?

Paul says God’s kindness is meant to lead you to repentance. Where is God’s kindness leading you to turn right now?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the gospel, the power for salvation.

Ask him to keep you from shame and make you bold.

Rest in his righteousness.

DAY 729 · WEEK 105

Romans 3:1-31

All have sinned; justification by faith

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 3:1-31. This chapter is the hinge of the letter. Read the verdict in 3:9-20 and then the great turn at 3:21, “But now.” Take your time with 3:21-26, one of the most important passages in the Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has argued that Gentiles (chapter 1) and Jews (chapter 2) are all under God’s judgment. Chapter 3 begins with objections: if the Jews are guilty too, what advantage has the Jew? Does unbelief cancel God’s faithfulness? Paul answers briefly, then delivers the verdict on the whole human race. Then, like sunrise, the next section begins with “But now.” The righteousness of God has been manifested.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “To begin with, the Jews were entrusted with the oracles of God” (3:2).
2. “None is righteous, no, not one” (3:10).
3. “For by works of the law no human being will be justified in his sight, since through the law comes knowledge of sin” (3:20).
4. “But now the righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the law, although the Law and the Prophets bear witness to it” (3:21).
5. “For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God” (3:23).
6. “And are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus” (3:24).
7. “Whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith” (3:25).

8 “For we hold that one is justified by faith apart from works of the law” (3:28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Jews have a real advantage: they were entrusted with the oracles of God, the Scriptures. But possessing the Bible is not the same as obeying it. Does Israel’s unfaithfulness nullify God’s faithfulness? “By no means! Let God be true though every one were a liar.” God’s character is not at stake in human failure. Paul answers a twisted objection, “Why not do evil that good may come?” with a short, firm rejection.

Then he gathers a series of Old Testament quotations, mostly from the Psalms and Isaiah, into a portrait of universal sin: “None is righteous, no, not one; no one understands; no one seeks for God. All have turned aside… no one does good, not even one.” Throats are open graves, feet are swift to shed blood, and “there is no fear of God before their eyes.” The point is stated at verse 19: “so that every mouth may be stopped, and the whole world may be held accountable to God.” The law cannot save because it was never given for that purpose. “Through the law comes knowledge of sin.” It is a mirror, not a rescue.

Then, “But now.” These two words mark the biggest turn in Romans. “The righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the law, although the Law and the Prophets bear witness to it.” This is the new covenant fulfillment of the old. The righteousness comes “through faith in Jesus Christ for all who believe. For there is no distinction: for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.”

Three words carry the weight. Justified: declared righteous in God’s courtroom. Grace: a free gift, not earned. Redemption: a slave market word for being bought back with a price. And then “whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith.” Propitiation means a sacrifice that satisfies God’s wrath. God himself provides it. Paul explains why: “This was to show God’s righteousness, because in his divine forbearance he had passed over former sins.” In the Old Testament, God forgave sin and seemed to overlook it. Now it is clear how he could do so justly: the cross. “So that he might be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus.” God is both just and the one who justifies the ungodly. That is the miracle.

Boasting is excluded. If salvation were by works, we could boast. It is by faith, so all glory goes to God. And this faith does not cancel the law; it upholds it, since Christ fulfilled it.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 14:1-3 and 53:1-3 describe human sin. Psalm 5:9, 10:7, 36:1, 140:3, and Isaiah 59:7-8 are quoted in verses 13-18. Leviticus 16 describes the Day of Atonement and the mercy seat, the background of "propitiation." Isaiah 53:4-6, 10-12 gives the Servant bearing sin. Proverbs 17:15 says that justifying the wicked is an abomination to the LORD, which makes the cross necessary. 2 Corinthians 5:21 says he became sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God. Galatians 2:16 and Ephesians 2:8-9 repeat the point.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Romans 3:23-24. They hold the whole gospel in two verses.

Ask whether you are secretly trying to earn God's favor. Let boasting be excluded today.

Thank God for the cross, where he is both just and the justifier.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have fallen short of his glory.
- Thank God for justifying you by grace as a gift.
- Thank Jesus for the redemption that is in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 105

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 3:23-24

DAY 730 · WEEK 105

Romans 3:21-31; Romans 4:1-8; Galatians 2:15-21

Justification by Faith Alone

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 3:21-31, Romans 4:1-8, and Galatians 2:15-21. Today is a doctrinal pause on justification by faith alone. Notice the legal language, the word “counted,” and what Paul says about works and grace.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Justification by faith alone was the central issue of the Protestant Reformation. Martin Luther called it “the article by which the church stands or falls.” It is also the point at which Paul argued against those who wanted Gentile believers to take on the Jewish law. In Galatians, Paul confronts Peter in Antioch because withdrawing from Gentile believers implied that faith in Christ was not enough. The three passages together show that being right with God has always been by grace through faith.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “But now the righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the law” (Romans 3:21).
2. “And are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus” (Romans 3:24).
3. “So that he might be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus” (Romans 3:26).
4. “For we hold that one is justified by faith apart from works of the law” (Romans 3:28).

5. “For what does the Scripture say? Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness” (Romans 4:3).
6. “And to the one who does not work but believes in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is counted as righteousness” (Romans 4:5).
7. “A person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ” (Galatians 2:16).
8. “If righteousness were through the law, then Christ died for no purpose” (Galatians 2:21).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

To justify is to declare righteous. It is a courtroom word, not a hospital word. It describes a change of status, not of nature. In justification, God declares the sinner to be in the right, forgiven and accepted, on the basis of Christ’s work and not our own. The Reformers described this as imputation: our sin is counted as Christ’s, and his righteousness is counted as ours. Paul uses the word “counted” (or “reckoned”) eleven times in Romans 4. The great exchange happens at the cross. God does not pretend we are righteous. He treats us as righteous because Christ is righteous in our place.

Faith is the instrument, not the cause. We are justified by grace (the source), through Christ’s blood and obedience (the ground), and through faith (the means). Faith does not earn anything. It is the empty hand that receives. And “alone” means that nothing is added to faith as a condition for being right with God. But the faith that justifies is never alone; it produces works. James 2 makes this point: a claim to faith that produces no obedience is dead. Paul and James are not opposed. Paul speaks of how we are declared righteous; James speaks of how true faith is shown to be real.

Justification is once for all. The verdict of the last day is announced in advance to those who believe. “Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God” (Romans 5:1). Not “will have” but “have.” Christians have long differed here with Roman Catholic teaching, which holds that justification includes a lifelong process of being made righteous through grace-enabled works and sacraments. Evangelicals hold that sanctification follows justification and does not form part of it. Scholars today also debate the “new perspective” on Paul, which emphasizes the inclusion of Gentiles; most evangelicals receive its insight about covenant community while insisting that Paul is also teaching how sinners stand right before a holy God.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul says that righteousness from God has been manifested "apart from the law." This does not mean the Old Testament was wrong. It means the Law and the Prophets "bear witness to it." They pointed forward to this. The righteousness comes through faith in Jesus Christ for all who believe, without distinction.

Then Paul turns to Abraham, the father of the Jewish people, to prove that justification by faith is not a New Testament novelty. "What then shall we say was gained by Abraham, our forefather according to the flesh? For if Abraham was justified by works, he has something to boast about, but not before God." He quotes Genesis 15:6: "Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness." Wages are earned and owed. A gift is received. "To the one who does not work but believes in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is counted as righteousness." Notice how startling the phrase "justifies the ungodly" is. Under Old Testament law, a judge who acquits the guilty is condemned (Proverbs 17:15). Yet God does exactly this, because the penalty has been paid.

Paul then brings David as a second witness. In Psalm 32, David speaks of the blessing of the one "whose lawless deeds are forgiven, and whose sins are covered; blessed is the man against whom the Lord will not count his sin." Forgiveness of sins and counted righteousness are two sides of the same coin.

In Galatians 2, Paul states the truth in personal terms. "We know that a person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ, so we also have believed in Christ Jesus, in order to be justified by faith in Christ and not by works of the law." And he draws the conclusion: "I do not nullify the grace of God, for if righteousness were through the law, then Christ died for no purpose." To add anything to faith as a requirement is to say that the cross was not enough. Those who try to be justified by the law are, in effect, setting aside Christ's death.

This doctrine is the believer's comfort and the church's boast. It does not make light of sin. It takes sin so seriously that it required the death of God's Son. And it gives certainty: our standing before God does not rise and fall with our performance, but rests on Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 15:6 is the verse behind Romans 4 and Galatians 3. Habakkuk 2:4 stands behind both letters. Psalm 32:1-2 is David's blessing of the forgiven. Isaiah 53:11 says the righteous one will make many to be accounted righteous. Jeremiah 23:6 calls the coming king "The LORD is

our righteousness.” 2 Corinthians 5:21 describes the exchange. Philippians 3:8-9 speaks of having a righteousness not my own. Ephesians 2:8-9 and Titus 3:4-7 teach salvation by grace through faith. James 2:14-26 describes faith that works.

STEP 6

Application

Write in your own words the difference between being declared righteous and being made righteous. Say it to someone this week.

When you feel guilty after failing, remind yourself that your standing before God rests on Christ’s work, not on your record.

Thank God for “counted as righteousness.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he justifies the ungodly.
- Tell him you bring nothing but faith, and even that is his gift.
- Ask him to keep you from trusting in your works.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 105

“For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.”

ROMANS 3:23-24

DAY 731 · WEEK 105

Romans 4:1-25

Abraham's faith counted as righteousness

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 25 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 4:1-25. Paul uses Abraham as a case study. Notice the timing of Abraham's faith, and the kind of faith that Paul describes.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Abraham was the Jewish people's founding father. Rabbis often taught that Abraham was justified because of his obedience, including his willingness to offer Isaac. If Paul can show that Abraham was right with God by faith, the Jewish objections collapse and the Gentiles are brought in. Genesis 15:6 is the verse on which Paul builds, and he reads it with great care.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For what does the Scripture say? Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness" (4:3).
2. "And to the one who does not work but believes in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is counted as righteousness" (4:5).
3. "Blessed are those whose lawless deeds are forgiven, and whose sins are covered" (4:7).
4. "It was not after, but before" (4:10).
5. "He received the sign of circumcision as a seal of the righteousness that he had by faith while he was still uncircumcised" (4:11).
6. "Who gives life to the dead and calls into existence the things that do not exist" (4:17).
7. "Fully convinced that God was able to do what he had promised" (4:21).
8. "Who was delivered up for our trespasses and raised for our justification" (4:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul starts with a question: what did Abraham find? If he was justified by works, he would have something to boast about, but not before God. The Scripture says that Abraham believed God and it was counted to him as righteousness. Notice the verb "counted." It is bookkeeping language. Righteousness was credited to his account, not earned.

Then Paul reasons from the timeline. When was Abraham counted righteous? Before or after circumcision? Genesis 15 comes before Genesis 17. Abraham was justified long before he was circumcised, and long before the law of Moses. Circumcision was a sign and seal of a righteousness he already had by faith. The consequence is wide: Abraham is the father of all who believe without being circumcised, so that righteousness may be counted to them as well, and the father of the circumcised who also walk in the footsteps of his faith. Jew and Gentile are in the same family on the same terms.

The promise to Abraham did not come through the law, since law brings wrath, but through the righteousness of faith. "That is why it depends on faith, in order that the promise may rest on grace and be guaranteed to all his offspring." This is a central point for understanding the covenants. The Abrahamic promise, that Abraham would be the father of many nations and heir of the world, is fulfilled in Christ, and all who share his faith are his children.

Abraham's faith is described with care. God had promised him a son, but he and Sarah were old; Abraham's body was as good as dead, and Sarah's womb was barren. Yet "no unbelief made him waver concerning the promise of God, but he grew strong in his faith as he gave glory to God, fully convinced that God was able to do what he had promised." He believed in a God "who gives life to the dead and calls into existence the things that do not exist." The faith that justifies is trust in the promise-keeping God, who raises the dead.

And the account was written for us. "It will be counted to us who believe in him who raised from the dead Jesus our Lord, who was delivered up for our trespasses and raised for our justification." The cross dealt with our sin; the resurrection is God's public declaration that the payment was accepted. Abraham looked ahead to the promise; we look back to the resurrection. The object of faith is the same God, the one who raises the dead.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 12:1-3, 15:1-6, and 17:1-14 are the Abrahamic narratives. Genesis 22 is the offering of Isaac. Galatians 3:6-9 and 3:26-29 make the same argument. Hebrews 11:8-19 describes Abraham's faith. James 2:21-24 views Abraham's works as evidence of his faith. Psalm 32 is

the psalm David wrote. Isaiah 51:1-2 calls Israel to look to Abraham. Luke 1:73-75 speaks of the oath sworn to Abraham. Romans 1:4 and 8:11 connect the resurrection with justification and life.

STEP 6

Application

Compare Abraham's faith with your own. What promise of God are you called to trust, even when it seems impossible?

Give glory to God today out loud. Faith grows by giving glory.

Thank God that the resurrection of Jesus is proof the payment was accepted.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for counting faith as righteousness.
- Tell him what promise you are trusting him for.
- Ask him to strengthen your faith like Abraham's.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 105

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 3:23-24

DAY 732 · WEEK 105

Psalm 32

Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 32. Paul quotes the first two verses in Romans 4:7-8. Read it as David's testimony of what it feels like to be justified, and notice the difference between hiding sin and confessing it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 32 is a psalm of David, called a "Maskil," which means a teaching psalm. It is traditionally linked to David's sin with Bathsheba and the long months of silence before Nathan confronted him (2 Samuel 11 to 12). It is one of the seven penitential psalms. Augustine loved it so much that he had it written on the wall beside his bed when he was dying. Paul read it in Romans 4 as proof that David knew the blessing of being counted righteous apart from works.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered" (v. 1).
2. "Blessed is the man against whom the LORD counts no iniquity, and in whose spirit there is no deceit" (v. 2).
3. "For when I kept silence, my bones wasted away through my groaning all day long" (v. 3).
4. "For day and night your hand was heavy upon me; my strength was dried up as by the heat of summer" (v. 4).
5. "I acknowledged my sin to you, and I did not cover my iniquity" (v. 5).

6. “I said, I will confess my transgressions to the LORD, and you forgave the iniquity of my sin” (v. 5).
7. “I will instruct you and teach you in the way you should go; I will counsel you with my eye upon you” (v. 8).
8. “Many are the sorrows of the wicked, but steadfast love surrounds the one who trusts in the LORD” (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a double beatitude: “Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered. Blessed is the man against whom the LORD counts no iniquity.” Three words for sin appear: transgression (rebellion), sin (missing the mark), and iniquity (twistedness). Three words for forgiveness answer them: forgiven (lifted away), covered, and not counted. Paul will pick up this last phrase, “counts no iniquity,” as the very meaning of justification. Notice that the blessing is not for the one who has never sinned, but for the one whose sin is dealt with.

Then David tells his story. He kept silence, hiding his sin. The result was physical and spiritual misery: his bones wasted away, he groaned all day, and God’s hand was heavy on him day and night. His strength dried up like a field in summer. Unconfessed sin is a heavy load, and the conscience is God’s instrument to press us toward him. Many people have lived with the weight of what they will not admit.

Then the turn: “I acknowledged my sin to you, and I did not cover my iniquity; I said, I will confess my transgressions to the LORD, and you forgave the iniquity of my sin.” The sequence is short. David said he would confess, and God forgave. The speed of God’s forgiveness is striking. There is no penance or delay. The result is relief and safety: in a time of distress the rising waters will not reach him. The LORD becomes a hiding place.

God speaks in verse 8: “I will instruct you and teach you in the way you should go; I will counsel you with my eye upon you.” Forgiveness leads to guidance. And then a warning not to be like a horse or mule that needs bit and bridle to stay near. God would rather lead by relationship than force.

The psalm ends with a call to joy: “Be glad in the LORD, and rejoice, you righteous, and shout for joy, all you upright in heart!” For Christians, the foundation of this joy is clearer than it was for David. Our sin was not simply passed over; it was covered by the blood of Christ. The one against whom the Lord counts no sin is the one who is in Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 4:6-8 quotes verses 1-2. 2 Samuel 12:13 records Nathan's word, "The LORD has put away your sin." Psalm 51 is David's longer prayer after the same sin. Proverbs 28:13 says whoever conceals his transgressions will not prosper. 1 John 1:5-10 teaches that if we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive. James 5:16 tells us to confess to one another. Hebrews 4:16 invites us to the throne of grace. Psalm 103:10-12 says he removes our transgressions as far as the east is from the west.

STEP 6

Application

Spend a few minutes confessing specific sins to the LORD. Name them. Then thank him for forgiving.

If you are hiding something from God or from a trusted friend, bring it into the light.

Read the last verse aloud as a call to joy.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Acknowledge your sin to God without covering it.
- Thank him for the forgiveness that makes you blessed.
- Ask him to be your hiding place.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 105

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 3:23-24

DAY 733 · WEEK 105

Psalm 130

With him is plentiful redemption

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 130. It is a Song of Ascents and one of the penitential psalms. Notice how the psalm moves from the depths to hope, and what the psalmist waits for.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 130 was sung by pilgrims as they climbed to Jerusalem. Martin Luther loved it and called it one of the "Pauline psalms" because it teaches justification by grace as clearly as Paul does. It is only eight verses. John Wesley is said to have heard it sung at St. Paul's Cathedral on the afternoon of the day his heart was "strangely warmed" in 1738.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Out of the depths I cry to you, O LORD!" (v. 1).
2. "O Lord, hear my voice! Let your ears be attentive to the voice of my pleas for mercy!" (v. 2).
3. "If you, O LORD, should mark iniquities, O Lord, who could stand?" (v. 3).
4. "But with you there is forgiveness, that you may be feared" (v. 4).
5. "I wait for the LORD, my soul waits, and in his word I hope" (v. 5).
6. "My soul waits for the Lord more than watchmen for the morning" (v. 6).
7. "For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption" (v. 7).
8. "And he will redeem Israel from all his iniquities" (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins at the bottom: “Out of the depths I cry to you, O LORD!” The depths are deep waters, a place of overwhelming trouble. The psalm makes clear that the deepest trouble is sin. The psalmist cries for mercy, aware that he has no claim on God.

The question in verse 3 is among the most searching in the Bible: “If you, O LORD, should mark iniquities, O Lord, who could stand?” The answer is no one. If God kept a record of every sin, no one would survive. This is Romans 3: none is righteous, no, not one. But the psalm turns on one word, “But.” “But with you there is forgiveness, that you may be feared.” The forgiveness is not a contradiction of God’s holiness. It is the result of his character. And the effect of forgiveness is not carelessness but reverence. The more we understand the cost of forgiveness, the more we fear God in the right way, with awe and love.

Next the psalmist waits. “I wait for the LORD, my soul waits, and in his word I hope.” He has no other support. He waits “more than watchmen for the morning,” repeated for emphasis. A night watchman on a city wall knows that morning will come, and longs for it. So the believer waits with certain hope for the LORD. Notice that hope is rooted in his word. The promises of God are the ground of waiting.

Then the psalmist turns to the whole community. “O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption.” The word “plentiful” means abundant, overflowing. There is more redemption in God than sin in us. “And he will redeem Israel from all his iniquities.” All of them. For us, this promise has been fulfilled at the cross. Jesus’ name means “he will save his people from their sins” (Matthew 1:21). The plentiful redemption has been paid.

The psalm moves from the depths to the dawn. Many Christians have prayed it in seasons of guilt, depression, and delay. It teaches us that the way out of the depths is to cry to the LORD, to cling to his forgiveness, and to wait for him with hope.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 51 and Psalm 32 are other penitential psalms. Exodus 34:6-7 tells of the LORD who forgives iniquity. Micah 7:18-19 asks who is a God like you, pardoning iniquity. Isaiah 40:31 speaks of those who wait on the LORD. Lamentations 3:25-26 says the LORD is good to those who wait for him. Matthew 1:21 gives the meaning of Jesus’ name. Titus 2:14 says Christ gave himself to redeem us from all lawlessness. Ephesians 1:7 says we have redemption through his blood. 1 Peter 1:18-19 speaks of the precious blood of Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Pray this psalm if you are in a low place. If you are not, pray it for someone who is.

Wait on the LORD in one area today without rushing. Let his word be your hope.

Count the gifts of redemption you have received in Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry to God out of the depths.
- Thank him that with him there is forgiveness and plentiful redemption.
- Wait for him and trust his word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 105

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 3:23-24

DAY 734 · WEEK 105

Psalm 143:1-12

Enter not into judgment with your servant

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 143. It is the last of the penitential psalms. Paul alludes to verse 2 in Romans 3:20 and Galatians 2:16. Notice the combination of confession, longing, and request for guidance.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 143 is a prayer of David, perhaps from the time when Absalom pursued him. The enemy is real, but the deeper problem is that David knows that he cannot stand on his own merit before God. Verse 2 is the key line, and Paul used it to prove that no one is justified by works. With Psalms 32 and 130, it completes a trio on the theme of coming to God as a sinner.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Hear my prayer, O LORD; give ear to my pleas for mercy! In your faithfulness answer me, in your righteousness!” (v. 1).
2. “Enter not into judgment with your servant, for no one living is righteous before you” (v. 2).
3. “Therefore my spirit faints within me; my heart within me is appalled” (v. 4).
4. “I remember the days of old; I meditate on all that you have done; I ponder the work of your hands” (v. 5).
5. “I stretch out my hands to you; my soul thirsts for you like a parched land” (v. 6).
6. “Let me hear in the morning of your steadfast love, for in you I trust” (v. 8).
7. “Teach me to do your will, for you are my God! Let your good Spirit lead me on level ground!” (v. 10).

8 “For your name’s sake, O LORD, preserve my life! In your righteousness bring my soul out of trouble!” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David opens by appealing to God’s faithfulness and righteousness. This is unusual. Normally one might expect him to appeal to his own innocence. Instead he appeals to God’s character. He is asking God to act in keeping with his own promises. And then the line that Paul loves: “Enter not into judgment with your servant, for no one living is righteous before you.” David does not argue his case. He asks God not to bring him to court, because he would lose. This is the prayer of a man who understands that he is not righteous in himself. It is close to the cry of Romans 3.

The enemy has crushed David’s life to the ground, and he sits in darkness like those long dead. His spirit faints and his heart is appalled. This is an honest picture of despair, and the Bible does not hide it. What does David do? He remembers. “I remember the days of old; I meditate on all that you have done; I ponder the work of your hands.” When the present is dark, he looks at what God has done in the past. For Christians, the great work to remember is the cross and the resurrection.

He stretches out his hands, and his soul thirsts for God like parched land. Verses 7 to 10 are a series of brief requests: answer me quickly; let me hear of your steadfast love in the morning; make me know the way I should go; deliver me; teach me to do your will. Notice the order. First he asks to hear of God’s love, and then for guidance. We cannot follow God’s will without first resting in his love. And the prayer, “Let your good Spirit lead me on level ground,” anticipates the Spirit’s guidance for the believer.

The final plea rests on God’s name: “For your name’s sake, O LORD, preserve my life! In your righteousness bring my soul out of trouble.” David does not ask because he deserves it, but for the sake of God’s glory. In the end, he asks God to cut off his enemies, “for I am your servant.” The psalm ends with confidence in the relationship, not in himself.

How does this prepare us for Romans 5? We have just learned that no living person is righteous before God. The answer to David’s fear is the gospel: in Christ, God does enter into judgment, but he enters it on our behalf. The Judge himself has stood in the dock in our place.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 3:20 and Galatians 2:16 allude to verse 2. Psalm 51 and Psalm 130 are related. Job 9:2 and 25:4 also ask how a man can be righteous before God. Psalm 77:11-12 also speaks of remembering God's works. Psalm 63:1 is another thirst psalm. Romans 8:14 says all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God. Nehemiah 9:20 says God gave his good Spirit to instruct. Hebrews 4:15-16 says we have a high priest who sympathizes with our weakness.

STEP 6

Application

Remember specific works of God in your life. Write down three.

Pray verse 8 tomorrow morning, before checking your phone: let me hear of your steadfast love.

Ask the Spirit to lead you on level ground, and listen for his answer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God not to enter into judgment with you, since no one living is righteous.
- Ask him to teach you to do his will.
- Ask him to lead you on level ground.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 105

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 3:23-24

DAY 735 · WEEK 105

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Romans 3:23-24 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 3:23-24

REST

Meditation

These two verses hold the whole gospel in a few lines. They tell the problem and the solution.

"For all have sinned." The word "all" leaves no exceptions. The Jew with the law and the Gentile without it, the moral and the immoral, the religious and the irreligious. No one is left out.

"And fall short of the glory of God." Sin is not only breaking rules. It is falling short of the purpose for which we were made: to reflect God's glory. We were made to image him, and we have failed.

"And are justified." Here is the turn. The word is a legal one: declared righteous, acquitted, accepted. This is God's verdict over those who believe.

"By his grace as a gift." Not by merit or effort, but freely. A gift cannot be earned, only received. Grace means undeserved favor, and the word "gift" underlines it.

“Through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.” Redemption means buying back, as a slave is ransomed. The price was the blood of Christ. All of this is “in Christ Jesus.” Outside of him there is no justification; in him there is no condemnation.

If you are tempted to think you are too bad to be forgiven, or good enough not to need it, say these verses. They fit both temptations.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw Paul’s verdict and the gospel that answers it. In Romans 3, every mouth was stopped: no one is righteous, and the law brings knowledge of sin. Then came the great “But now”: the righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the law, and we are justified by grace as a gift, through the redemption in Christ Jesus, whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood. In a doctrinal pause, you studied justification by faith alone: God declares sinners righteous because Christ’s righteousness is counted as theirs. Romans 4 used Abraham, who believed God and was counted righteous before circumcision and long before the law. Three psalms of repentance gave the heart’s side: Psalm 32, the blessing of the one whose sin is not counted; Psalm 130, with the LORD there is plentiful redemption; and Psalm 143, enter not into judgment with your servant.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Which do you find harder to believe: that you are a sinner who cannot save yourself, or that you are fully forgiven and accepted in Christ? Why?

Paul says Jesus was put forward as a propitiation so that God could be both just and the justifier of the one who has faith. How does the cross show both God’s justice and God’s love at once?

David hid his sin and his bones wasted away, and then he confessed and was forgiven. Is there a sin you have been carrying in silence? What would it look like to confess it this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are justified by grace as a gift.

Rest in the work that Christ finished.

Tell him that you are not earning it.

DAY 736 · WEEK 106

Romans 5:1-21

Peace with God; Adam and Christ

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 5:1-21. The chapter moves from the benefits of justification to the way sin and grace work in history through two men, Adam and Christ. Read verses 1-11 for the experience of salvation, and 12-21 for the structure of salvation history.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapters 1 to 4 have shown that we are justified by faith. Chapter 5 begins with the word "Therefore." What follows from justification? First, peace, access, and hope. Then Paul steps back and places the whole human story in two heads: Adam, in whom all die, and Christ, in whom all who believe are made alive. This is a pivotal chapter for understanding how the covenants fit together.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ" (5:1).
2. "And hope does not put us to shame, because God's love has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit who has been given to us" (5:5).
3. "But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us" (5:8).
4. "For if while we were enemies we were reconciled to God by the death of his Son, much more, now that we are reconciled, shall we be saved by his life" (5:10).
5. "Therefore, just as sin came into the world through one man, and death through sin, and so death spread to all men because all sinned" (5:12).

6 “Adam, who was a type of the one who was to come” (5:14).

7 “For as by the one man’s disobedience the many were made sinners, so by the one man’s obedience the many will be made righteous” (5:19).

8 “But where sin increased, grace abounded all the more” (5:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God.” This is peace as a status, an end to hostility. We were enemies, and now we are at peace. We have access by faith into the grace in which we stand, and we rejoice in the hope of the glory of God. Paul even says we rejoice in our sufferings, because suffering produces endurance, endurance character, and character hope. And hope does not disappoint us because God’s love has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit. Notice that all three persons of the Trinity are active: peace with God the Father through the Son, and the Spirit pouring love into our hearts.

The proof of God’s love is the cross. “While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” We were weak, ungodly, sinners, and enemies. Few would die for a righteous man, though perhaps for a good man someone would dare. But Christ died for the ungodly. And Paul reasons from the greater to the lesser: if God did the hard thing while we were enemies, he will do the easy thing now that we are reconciled. We will be saved from the wrath through him. We rejoice in God through our Lord Jesus Christ, through whom we have now received reconciliation.

Then comes the great comparison, from verse 12. Sin entered the world through one man, Adam, and death through sin, so death spread to all because all sinned. This does not simply mean that Adam set a bad example. Adam acted as the head of the human race, and what he did had consequences for all who were in him. Christians have explained the details differently: some hold that Adam’s guilt is directly counted to us (the federal headship view), others that we inherit a corrupt nature and then sin ourselves. All agree that sin and death came through Adam and cannot be escaped by our own efforts. Paul calls Adam “a type of the one who was to come.”

Christ is the second Adam. The parallel is not exact: the free gift is not like the trespass. If many died through one man’s trespass, much more have the grace of God and the free gift by the grace of the one man Jesus Christ abounded for many. As one trespass led to condemnation for all, so one act of righteousness leads to justification and life. The point is stated plainly: “as by the one man’s disobedience the many were made sinners, so by the one man’s obedience the many will be made righteous.”

Where did the law fit in? It came in to increase the trespass, to show the true nature of sin, "but where sin increased, grace abounded all the more, so that, as sin reigned in death, grace also might reign through righteousness leading to eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord." Grace wins. Grace is stronger than sin.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 2 to 3 is the account of Adam and the fall. 1 Corinthians 15:21-22 and 15:45-49 contrast Adam and Christ. Luke 3:38 and Luke 4 show Jesus as the second Adam, tested in the wilderness. Hebrews 2:5-18 speaks of Christ as the true Man. Colossians 1:19-22 speaks of reconciliation. 2 Corinthians 5:18-21 is the ministry of reconciliation. Ephesians 2:1-10 describes our being made alive. Isaiah 53:11 says the righteous one will make many to be accounted righteous. 1 John 4:10 says love consists in that he loved us and sent his Son.

STEP 6

Application

Count your suffering as a means God uses to build hope. Is there an area where you can see this?

Meditate on Romans 5:8 today. Let it silence your doubts about God's love.

Thank Jesus for being the second Adam, who obeyed where Adam failed.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for peace with him through Jesus.
- Thank him for pouring his love into your heart by the Spirit.
- Thank him for loving you while you were a sinner.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 106

"But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

ROMANS 5:8

DAY 737 · WEEK 106

Romans 6:1-14; Galatians 2:20; Ephesians 2:4-10

Union with Christ

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 6:1-14, Galatians 2:20, and Ephesians 2:4-10. Today is a doctrinal pause on union with Christ. Notice the repeated phrase “with him” and “in Christ,” and how the believer’s past, present, and future are bound to his.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

If we are justified by grace and where sin increased grace abounded all the more, a person might ask: why not keep sinning so that grace may increase? Paul replies with horror, “By no means!” and gives his answer: a believer cannot go on living in sin, because he has been united to Christ in his death and resurrection. Union with Christ is the deepest category of the Christian life. John Calvin said that Christ and all his benefits come to us through union with him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Do you not know that all of us who have been baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death?” (Romans 6:3).
2. “We were buried therefore with him by baptism into death, in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead by the glory of the Father, we too might walk in newness of life” (Romans 6:4).
3. “For if we have been united with him in a death like his, we shall certainly be united with him in a resurrection like his” (Romans 6:5).
4. “We know that our old self was crucified with him in order that the body of sin might be brought to nothing, so that we would no longer be enslaved to sin” (Romans 6:6).

5. “So you also must consider yourselves dead to sin and alive to God in Christ Jesus” (Romans 6:11).
6. “I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me” (Galatians 2:20).
7. “And raised us up with him and seated us with him in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus” (Ephesians 2:6).
8. “For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God” (Ephesians 2:8).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Union with Christ means that every believer is joined to Christ by the Spirit through faith, so that what is true of him becomes true of us. The New Testament expresses this in phrases such as “in Christ,” “with Christ,” and “Christ in you,” which appear well over a hundred times. This is not a mere figure of speech. It is a real, spiritual, and personal bond. Paul uses images: a body and its head, a vine and its branches, a husband and wife, a building and its cornerstone.

Union with Christ is the source of every saving benefit. Justification: we are counted righteous because we are in him. Sanctification: we are changed because we share his death and resurrection life. Adoption: we are sons because we are in the Son. Perseverance: nothing can separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus. And glorification: we will be raised as he was raised. It also shows why the gospel is not only forgiveness but a new life. In Romans 6, the believer’s old self was crucified with Christ, and he now walks in newness of life. The old master, sin, has lost its dominion.

Notice the three tenses of union with Christ. We have died with him (past). We now live to God in him (present). We will be raised with him (future). In Ephesians 2, Paul speaks of the future as already done: God “raised us up with him and seated us with him in the heavenly places.” Our life is hidden with Christ in God (Colossians 3:3).

Christians differ on whether “baptized into Christ” in Romans 6:3 refers primarily to water baptism, or to the Spirit’s baptism that joins us to Christ, which water baptism pictures. Baptists and Presbyterians also differ about who should be baptized and how. All agree that baptism points to the union with Christ in his death and resurrection that is received by faith.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul's question, "Are we to continue in sin that grace may abound?" is answered, "By no means! How can we who died to sin still live in it?" The believer's relationship to sin has been broken, not because he has become sinless, but because he has died. He now belongs to another.

"Do you not know that all of us who have been baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death?" Paul assumes that every Christian knows this. Baptism pictures union: we go under with Christ in death and come up with him in resurrection. The purpose is clear: "that we too might walk in newness of life." The Christian life is not a self-improvement program. It is a resurrection life.

The logic is expressed in verses 5 to 7: "If we have been united with him in a death like his, we shall certainly be united with him in a resurrection like his." The "old self," the person we were in Adam, was crucified with Christ. The result is not perfection, but freedom: we are no longer slaves to sin. "For one who has died has been set free from sin." And then comes the command, in three steps. First "consider": "You also must consider yourselves dead to sin and alive to God in Christ Jesus." Count it true. Then, "Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal body." Finally, present yourselves to God. The commands are built on the indicatives. We obey because of who we are in Christ.

Galatians 2:20 is the personal confession: "I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me. And the life I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me." Notice the final clause. Paul's identity is bound up with Christ's love and self-giving.

Ephesians 2 sets the same truth in a wider frame. We were dead in trespasses, but God, being rich in mercy, made us alive together with Christ, raised us up with him, and seated us with him in the heavenly places. Why? "So that in the coming ages he might show the immeasurable riches of his grace in kindness toward us in Christ Jesus." And it is all of grace: "For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God."

STEP 5

Connection

John 15:1-8 is the vine and the branches. Colossians 2:11-13 and 3:1-4 speak of being buried and raised with Christ. 2 Corinthians 5:17 says if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. 1 Corinthians 12:12-13 describes the body of Christ. Ephesians 1:3-14 lists the blessings "in

Christ." Ephesians 5:25-32 speaks of the mystery of Christ and the church. Galatians 3:26-29 says all are one in Christ Jesus. Romans 8:1 says there is no condemnation for those in Christ Jesus. 2 Peter 1:4 speaks of sharing in the divine nature.

STEP 6

Application

Say the word "consider" to yourself today when you are tempted: consider yourself dead to sin and alive to God in Christ Jesus.

Read Galatians 2:20 aloud and make it your own confession.

Think about baptism, yours or someone else's, as a picture of union with Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that in Christ you have died to sin and been raised to new life.
- Ask him to help you live in that union.
- Tell him where you are tempted to live as if it were not true.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 106

"But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

ROMANS 5:8

DAY 738 · WEEK 106

Romans 6:1-23

Dead to sin, alive to God; slaves of righteousness

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 6:1-23. You studied the first half of this chapter in the doctrinal pause on union with Christ. Today read the whole chapter, and focus on the language of slavery and freedom in verses 15-23.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has said that believers have died to sin. In the second half of chapter 6, he uses the picture of slavery to explain the change of masters. Everyone serves something. The question is not whether we will be slaves but whose. Paul's readers in Rome knew slavery well, and the image was both vivid and humbling.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "What shall we say then? Are we to continue in sin that grace may abound?" (6:1).
2. "By no means! How can we who died to sin still live in it?" (6:2).
3. "For one who has died has been set free from sin" (6:7).
4. "Present yourselves to God as those who have been brought from death to life" (6:13).
5. "But thanks be to God, that you who were once slaves of sin have become obedient from the heart to the standard of teaching to which you were committed" (6:17).
6. "And, having been set free from sin, have become slaves of righteousness" (6:18).
7. "But now that you have been set free from sin and have become slaves of God, the fruit you get leads to sanctification and its end, eternal life" (6:22).
8. "For the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord" (6:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter opens with an objection that Paul takes very seriously. If grace is free, why not sin more? The answer in the first half is union with Christ. In the second half, Paul adds a second argument: the idea of two masters.

In verses 12 to 14, he gives practical commands. “Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal body, to make you obey its passions.” Sin is a king. It still tries to rule. Do not present your members, hands, eyes, tongue, to sin as instruments of unrighteousness, but present yourselves to God as those who have been brought from death to life. And the promise: “Sin will have no dominion over you, since you are not under law but under grace.” Grace is not a license, but a power.

Then the second question: “Are we to sin because we are not under law but under grace? By no means!” Paul turns to slavery. “Do you not know that if you present yourselves to anyone as obedient slaves, you are slaves of the one whom you obey, either of sin, which leads to death, or of obedience, which leads to righteousness?” There is no neutral ground. We are slaves of sin or slaves of righteousness. But the change has happened: “Thanks be to God, that you who were once slaves of sin have become obedient from the heart to the standard of teaching to which you were committed.” The gospel has teaching, and obedience from the heart is the evidence of conversion.

The paradox is that serving God is freedom. Slavery to sin offers apparent liberty but delivers shame: “What fruit were you getting at that time from the things of which you are now ashamed? For the end of those things is death.” Slavery to God yields fruit that leads to sanctification and its end, eternal life. The believer’s obedience is not a way to earn salvation, but a growing holiness that expresses it.

The chapter ends with one of the best-known verses of Romans: “For the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.” Wages are earned; a gift is not. Sin pays what it owes: death. God gives what we have not earned: eternal life. And it is found only “in Christ Jesus our Lord.” The verse sums up the whole letter so far.

STEP 5

Connection

John 8:34-36 says everyone who commits sin is a slave to sin, but the Son sets free. Galatians 5:1 says for freedom Christ has set us free. 1 Peter 2:16 calls us to live as people who are free, yet servants of God. Matthew 6:24 says no one can serve two masters. Ephesians 2:1-3 describes our former life. 2 Timothy 2:19 speaks of departing from iniquity. Titus 2:11-14 speaks of grace training us to renounce ungodliness. Genesis 2:17 and Ezekiel 18:20 speak of death as the wage of sin.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what has been mastering you. Name the idol, habit, or fear that most often rules your decisions.

Present yourself to God today. Give him your hands, your eyes, and your tongue for one task.

Memorize Romans 6:23 and share it with a friend.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for setting you free from sin.

Offer yourself to him as an instrument of righteousness, and name one way.

Ask him not to let sin reign in you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 106

"But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

ROMANS 5:8

DAY 739 · WEEK 106

Romans 7:1-25

The law's limits; the wretched man's cry

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 25 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 7:1-25. This is one of the most debated chapters in the Bible. Read verses 1-6 on being released from the law, verses 7-13 on the law and sin, and verses 14-25 on the struggle. Notice the cry in verse 24 and the answer in verse 25.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has said that believers are not under law but under grace (6:14). A listener might ask, "Is the law then sin?" Chapter 7 answers. The law is holy, righteous, and good, but it cannot save or sanctify, because it meets a heart already enslaved to sin. The chapter ends with the cry of a man who sees the war within himself. Christians have argued for centuries about who this "I" is.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Likewise, my brothers, you also have died to the law through the body of Christ, so that you may belong to another, to him who has been raised from the dead, in order that we may bear fruit for God" (7:4).
2. "What shall we say then? That the law is sin? By no means! Yet if it had not been for the law, I would not have known sin" (7:7).
3. "So then, the law is holy, and the commandment is holy and righteous and good" (7:12).
4. "For I do not understand my own actions. For I do not do what I want, but I do the very thing I hate" (7:15).
5. "For I know that nothing good dwells in me, that is, in my flesh" (7:18).
6. "For I delight in the law of God, in my inner being" (7:22).

7. “Wretched man that I am! Who will deliver me from this body of death?” (7:24).

8. “Thanks be to God through Jesus Christ our Lord!” (7:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul opens with an illustration from marriage. A wife is bound to her husband as long as he lives; if he dies, she is free to marry another. In the same way, believers have “died to the law through the body of Christ, so that you may belong to another, to him who has been raised from the dead.” The goal is fruit for God. Before, “our sinful passions, aroused by the law, were at work in our members to bear fruit for death.” Now we serve “in the new way of the Spirit and not in the old way of the written code.” This is the contrast between the old covenant and the new, a key idea in the progressive covenantal reading: the Mosaic covenant has served its purpose and been fulfilled in Christ.

Is the law then to blame? “By no means!” The law shows what sin is. Paul uses the tenth commandment, “You shall not covet,” as an example. Sin took the opportunity in the commandment to produce all kinds of covetousness. “So the law is holy, and the commandment is holy and righteous and good.” The problem is not the law but sin, which uses the good law to show its evil.

Then, from verse 14, Paul shifts into the present tense and speaks of a deep inner conflict. “I do not do what I want, but I do the very thing I hate.” “I have the desire to do what is right, but not the ability to carry it out.” “I delight in the law of God, in my inner being, but I see in my members another law waging war against the law of my mind.” He cries: “Wretched man that I am! Who will deliver me from this body of death?” And the answer: “Thanks be to God through Jesus Christ our Lord!”

Who is this speaker? Faithful interpreters differ. Some (Augustine in his later writings, Luther, Calvin, and many Reformed writers) see the regenerate Christian, because the speaker delights in God’s law and hates sin, which an unbeliever would not. Others (Origen, and many modern scholars) see Paul describing the person under the law before Christ, or Israel under Sinai, speaking in the first person for dramatic effect. Both agree on the main point: the law cannot rescue, and only Christ can. Both also agree that the believer’s experience includes a real struggle with remaining sin (Galatians 5:17). The cry of verse 24 is not the last word. Chapter 8 begins, “There is therefore now no condemnation.”

If you have felt this conflict, you are not strange. It is evidence that something has changed, that you want what is good. The answer is not to try harder but to look to the deliverer.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 20:17 is the tenth commandment. Jeremiah 31:31-34 and Ezekiel 36:26-27 promise the new covenant. Galatians 5:16-24 describes the war between flesh and Spirit. Galatians 3:19-25 explains the purpose of the law as a guardian until Christ. 2 Corinthians 3:4-18 contrasts the old and new covenants. Hebrews 8:6-13 says the new covenant is better. Psalm 119 shows delight in the law. 1 John 1:8-2:2 deals with remaining sin and our advocate.

STEP 6

Application

Name an area where you do what you do not want. Bring it to Christ, not just to your willpower.

Say verse 25 aloud as an answer to your own wretchedness.

Thank God that the law is holy, and that Christ has done what the law could not.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you do what you hate and fail to do what you want.
- Cry, “Wretched man that I am,” and thank him for Jesus.
- Thank him that there is now no condemnation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 106

“But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us.”

ROMANS 5:8

DAY 740 · WEEK 106

Romans 6:1-14; 1 Thessalonians 4:1-8; Philippians 2:12-13

Sanctification

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 6:1-14, 1 Thessalonians 4:1-8, and Philippians 2:12-13. Today is a doctrinal pause on sanctification: how God makes believers holy. Notice who acts and what the believer is told to do.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After chapters on justification and a chapter on the war within, Romans moves toward the Spirit's work in chapter 8. Today we pause to ask: if we are justified by faith alone, how does a Christian grow? The New Testament uses the word sanctification to describe the process of being made holy, set apart for God and conformed to the image of Christ. Paul wrote to the Thessalonians, a young church in a pagan city, to urge them to live in holiness. And to the Philippians he gave the famous pairing of God's work and ours.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal body, to make you obey its passions" (Romans 6:12).
2. "But present yourselves to God as those who have been brought from death to life" (Romans 6:13).
3. "For sin will have no dominion over you, since you are not under law but under grace" (Romans 6:14).
4. "That, as you received from us how you ought to walk and to please God, just as you are doing, you do so more and more" (1 Thessalonians 4:1).

5. “For this is the will of God, your sanctification” (1 Thessalonians 4:3).
6. “For God has not called us for impurity, but in holiness” (1 Thessalonians 4:7).
7. “Work out your own salvation with fear and trembling” (Philippians 2:12).
8. “For it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure” (Philippians 2:13).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Sanctification is the work of God by which he makes believers holy. The Bible speaks of it in three ways. First, definitive sanctification: at conversion, every believer is set apart for God. Paul calls the Corinthians “sanctified in Christ Jesus” even while he rebukes them (1 Corinthians 1:2). Second, progressive sanctification: throughout life, the Spirit conforms us to Christ, so that we put to death the old ways and grow in love, joy, peace, patience, and the rest of the fruit of the Spirit. Third, final sanctification: when Christ returns, we will be made perfectly like him (1 John 3:2).

The key to Philippians 2:12-13 is that both are true at once. “Work out your own salvation” does not mean earn it; it means carry it into every area of life. And the reason is: “for it is God who works in you, both to will and to work.” God’s work does not replace ours; it empowers it. We are active, but we are not alone. This is why Christians pray, read, fight sin, and serve, and then give God the credit.

Sanctification differs from justification. Justification is a legal declaration, once for all and complete, while sanctification is a lifelong process that is never completed in this life. Justification is wholly God’s act, while in sanctification we cooperate by the Spirit’s power. But they cannot be separated. Everyone whom God justifies, he sanctifies. Holiness is not a condition for being accepted; it is the fruit of being accepted.

The ordinary means of sanctification are the word of God, prayer, the fellowship of the church, the Lord’s Supper, and suffering. Christians differ about whether believers can reach a state of entire sanctification or sinless perfection in this life. Wesleyans hold that perfect love is possible; Reformed Christians hold that sin remains until death while the Spirit’s work grows. All agree that the call to holiness is real and urgent, and that no one can see the Lord without it (Hebrews 12:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Romans 6:12-14, Paul uses commands that rest on the facts of union with Christ. Do not let sin reign. Do not offer your members to sin. Offer yourselves to God. The ground of obedience is grace: "You are not under law but under grace." The law could command but not empower. Grace both forgives and strengthens. This is why the New Testament never treats holiness as a condition of salvation but always as its result.

In 1 Thessalonians 4, Paul writes to young believers who have turned from idols. "This is the will of God, your sanctification: that you abstain from sexual immorality; that each of you know how to control his own body in holiness and honor, not in the passion of lust like the Gentiles who do not know God." Sanctification is concrete. It touches our bodies, our habits, our relationships. And Paul adds that "God has not called us for impurity, but in holiness. Therefore whoever disregards this, disregards not man but God, who gives his Holy Spirit to you." The Spirit is the Holy Spirit, and he is the one who makes us holy. Notice that Paul urges them to do this "more and more." Growth is expected.

The pairing in Philippians 2 is the most balanced summary. "Work out your own salvation with fear and trembling." The phrase conveys reverence, not terror. And then the encouragement: God is the one at work in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure. Even the desire to obey is his gift. This should keep us from pride when we obey and from despair when we fail.

So what do you do? Fight sin by the Spirit, using the means of grace. Remember who you are in Christ. Confess when you fall, and get up. And trust the one who began a good work in you to bring it to completion (Philippians 1:6).

STEP 5

Connection

1 Corinthians 1:2 and 6:11 speak of being sanctified. John 17:17 is Jesus' prayer, "Sanctify them in the truth; your word is truth." Romans 8:13 says by the Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body. Galatians 5:16-25 describes walking by the Spirit. 2 Corinthians 3:18 says we are being transformed into the same image. Hebrews 12:1-14 speaks of strife toward holiness. 1 Peter 1:13-16 calls us to be holy as he is holy. 1 John 3:2-3 gives the final hope. Ezekiel 36:27 promises the Spirit to cause us to walk in his statutes.

STEP 6

Application

Choose one specific area of obedience to work on this week. Ask the Spirit for help, and tell someone who will ask you about it.

When you obey, thank God. When you fail, confess and move on. Neither pride nor despair.

Read Philippians 1:6 as an encouragement that God will finish what he began.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for setting you apart in Christ.

Ask him to work in you both to will and to work for his good pleasure.

Tell him where you want to grow.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 106

"But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

ROMANS 5:8

DAY 741 · WEEK 106

Romans 8:1-39

No condemnation; the Spirit; nothing separates us

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 39 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 8:1-39. Many Christians call this the greatest chapter in the Bible. Read it slowly, perhaps in two sittings: verses 1-17 on life in the Spirit, and verses 18-39 on suffering, glory, and the love of God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 7 ended with the cry "Wretched man that I am!" Chapter 8 begins with the answer: no condemnation. The Holy Spirit, mentioned only a few times in the first seven chapters, appears nearly twenty times here. The chapter moves from the Spirit's work within, to the groaning of creation, to the unbreakable love of God. It is a summit of the Bible, and many believers have memorized it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (8:1).
2. "You, however, are not in the flesh but in the Spirit, if in fact the Spirit of God dwells in you" (8:9).
3. "For you did not receive the spirit of slavery to fall back into fear, but you have received the Spirit of adoption as sons, by whom we cry, Abba! Father!" (8:15).
4. "For I consider that the sufferings of this present time are not worth comparing with the glory that is to be revealed to us" (8:18).
5. "And we know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose" (8:28).
6. "If God is for us, who can be against us?" (8:31).

7. “He who did not spare his own Son but gave him up for us all, how will he not also with him graciously give us all things?” (8:32).

8. “Nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord” (8:39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.” The word “now” is emphatic: the verdict is already given. The reason: “the law of the Spirit of life has set you free in Christ Jesus from the law of sin and death.” What the law could not do, weakened by the flesh, God did: by sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh and for sin, he condemned sin in the flesh. The condemnation fell on Christ so that none falls on us. And the result is that the righteous requirement of the law is fulfilled in us, who walk according to the Spirit.

Verses 5 to 11 contrast two ways of living: the mind set on the flesh is death, and the mind set on the Spirit is life and peace. Every Christian has the Spirit: “Anyone who does not have the Spirit of Christ does not belong to him.” And the Spirit who raised Jesus from the dead will give life to our mortal bodies. The resurrection is already at work in us.

Verses 12 to 17 speak of adoption. We are not debtors to the flesh. By the Spirit we put to death the deeds of the body. All who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God. The Spirit does not make us fearful slaves but sons who cry “Abba! Father!” (an Aramaic word of intimate address). The Spirit himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God, and if children, then heirs, fellow heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with him so that we may also be glorified with him.

Verses 18 to 27 deal with suffering. The present sufferings are not worth comparing with the coming glory. Creation itself waits with eager longing, subjected to futility, groaning as in the pains of childbirth. We also groan, waiting for adoption, the redemption of our bodies. “In this hope we were saved.” And the Spirit helps us in our weakness: “We do not know what to pray for as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words.”

Then the golden chain. “We know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose.” This is not that all things are good, but that God works all things for the good of his people, and the good is defined in verse 29: to be conformed to the image of his Son. “For those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son… and those whom he predestined he also called, and those whom he called he also justified, and those whom he justified he also glorified.” Notice

that the chain has no broken links. Everyone who is justified will be glorified. Christians differ about the meaning of "foreknew": Reformed readers hold that it means God set his love on them beforehand, while others hold that it refers to God's foreknowledge of their faith. All agree that salvation is secured by God's purpose.

Paul ends with a series of questions that no one can answer against us. "If God is for us, who can be against us?" "He who did not spare his own Son but gave him up for us all, how will he not also with him graciously give us all things?" "Who shall bring any charge against God's elect? It is God who justifies." "Who is to condemn? Christ Jesus is the one who died, more than that, who was raised, who is at the right hand of God, who indeed is interceding for us." "Who shall separate us from the love of Christ?" Not tribulation, distress, persecution, famine, nakedness, danger, or sword. "In all these things we are more than conquerors through him who loved us." And the closing: "neither death nor life, nor angels nor rulers, nor things present nor things to come, nor powers, nor height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord."

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 5:1-11 anticipates the confidence of this chapter. John 14:15-17 and 16:7-15 promise the Spirit. Galatians 4:4-7 also speaks of the Spirit of adoption. Genesis 3:17-19 explains why creation groans. Isaiah 65:17-25 and Revelation 21:1-5 promise a new creation. Ephesians 1:3-14 speaks of election and the Spirit as a seal. Philippians 1:6 and John 10:28-29 assure perseverance. Psalm 44:22 is quoted in verse 36. Hebrews 7:25 says Christ always lives to make intercession for us. 1 John 4:9-10 speaks of God's love in sending his Son.

STEP 6

Application

Read verse 1 aloud, and put your name in it: there is now no condemnation for me.

Name a present suffering. Compare it to the glory to come, as Paul does, without minimizing the pain.

Memorize verses 38 and 39. Say them when you wake in the night.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that there is now no condemnation for you in Christ.

Thank him for the Spirit of adoption who lets you cry, “Abba, Father.”

Tell him what you want to be sure cannot separate you from his love.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 106

“But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us.”

ROMANS 5:8

DAY 742 · WEEK 106

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Romans 5:8 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

ROMANS 5:8

REST

Meditation

This verse is the center of the gospel in a single sentence.

"But God shows his love for us." The verse begins with a contrast. The previous verses spoke of how rare it is for anyone to die for another. "But God." His love is a different kind of love. The word "shows" means to demonstrate or prove. The cross is God's own demonstration of his love.

"In that while we were still sinners." Notice the timing. Not after we cleaned up, or when we decided to follow him. We were still sinners, still enemies, still without strength. God's love does not wait for us to be lovable.

"Christ died for us." Here is the proof. God did not simply declare love; he acted at great cost. Christ died, and he died "for us," in our place and for our benefit.

This verse is not just history; it is the foundation for security. If God loved us when we were sinners, how much more will he keep us now that we are his children (5:9-10)? Our assurance does not rest on our record but on his demonstration.

When you doubt that God loves you, say this verse. The cross is the answer.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw what flows from justification. Romans 5 began with peace with God, access to grace, and hope that does not put us to shame, and then traced our story in two heads: Adam, through whom sin and death came, and Christ, through whom the free gift of righteousness and life comes. A doctrinal pause on union with Christ showed that believers have died and risen with him. Romans 6 answered the charge that grace encourages sin: we were slaves of sin and have become slaves of righteousness, and the wages of sin is death but the free gift of God is eternal life. Romans 7 gave the struggle with the law and the cry of the wretched man, answered by Jesus Christ our Lord. A second doctrinal pause considered sanctification, in which God works in us both to will and to work. Then Romans 8 opened with no condemnation and closed with the unbreakable love of God.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says God showed his love for us while we were still sinners. How does it change you to know that God's love did not wait for you to improve?

Romans 5 says that in Adam all died and in Christ all who believe are made righteous. Where do you still try to live as if you were under Adam's headship, relying on yourself?

Romans 8:1 says there is now no condemnation. Which voice do you hear most often, the voice of condemnation or the voice of the Spirit? What would it take to listen to the second?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for dying for you while you were still a sinner.

Ask him to silence the voice of condemnation.

Rest in his love.

DAY 743 · WEEK 107

Romans 9:1-33

God's sovereign election; Israel and the promise

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 33 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 9:1-33. This chapter begins three chapters (9 to 11) on God's purposes for Israel. Read it prayerfully, noting Paul's sorrow, his focus on God's mercy, and the question of who belongs to Israel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Romans 8 ended with the certainty that nothing can separate believers from God's love. A Jewish reader might object: if God's promises to Israel have failed, how can we trust his promises to us? Paul takes up this question in chapters 9 to 11. Chapter 9 explains that God's word has not failed, because the promise always worked by election, not by physical descent. This chapter has been argued over for centuries, and it deserves careful and humble reading.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I have great sorrow and unceasing anguish in my heart" (9:2).
2. "To them belong the adoption, the glory, the covenants, the giving of the law, the worship, and the promises" (9:4).
3. "But it is not as though the word of God has failed. For not all who are descended from Israel belong to Israel" (9:6).
4. "For he says to Moses, I will have mercy on whom I have mercy, and I will have compassion on whom I have compassion" (9:15).
5. "So then it depends not on human will or exertion, but on God, who has mercy" (9:16).
6. "But who are you, O man, to answer back to God?" (9:20).

7. “Those who were not my people I will call my people, and her who was not beloved I will call beloved” (9:25).

8. “Behold, I am laying in Zion a stone of stumbling, and a rock of offense; and whoever believes in him will not be put to shame” (9:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with grief. “I am speaking the truth in Christ… I have great sorrow and unceasing anguish in my heart. For I could wish that I myself were accursed and cut off from Christ for the sake of my brothers.” Like Moses, who asked to be blotted out for the sake of the people (Exodus 32:32), Paul loves his people so much that he would give up his own salvation if it could save them. This is the heart of a missionary. Any teaching of election that does not produce this kind of love has missed the point.

He lists Israel’s privileges: adoption, glory, covenants, the law, worship, promises, patriarchs, and “from their race, according to the flesh, is the Christ, who is God over all, blessed forever.” This is one of the clearest statements of Christ’s deity.

Then the key claim: “It is not as though the word of God has failed. For not all who are descended from Israel belong to Israel.” The true Israel was always defined by God’s promise, not by physical descent. Isaac, not Ishmael. Jacob, not Esau, chosen “though they were not yet born and had done nothing either good or bad, in order that God’s purpose of election might continue, not because of works but because of him who calls.” “Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated,” a Hebrew idiom of preference, citing Malachi 1:2-3.

Paul anticipates the objection: “Is there injustice on God’s part? By no means!” He cites Moses: “I will have mercy on whom I have mercy.” Salvation “depends not on human will or exertion, but on God, who has mercy.” Pharaoh is the example of one who was hardened, so that God’s power might be shown. The potter and the clay: “Who are you, O man, to answer back to God?” God has the right to show wrath and make known his power, and to make known the riches of his glory for vessels of mercy, “whom he has prepared beforehand for glory, even us whom he has called, not from the Jews only but also from the Gentiles.”

Christians differ on how to read this chapter. Reformed interpreters see individual election to salvation: God sovereignly chooses those he will save. Others (Arminian and many other evangelicals) read the chapter as corporate election, focused on groups and on God’s purposes in history, or hold that God elects in view of foreseen faith. Everyone agrees on what Paul emphasizes: salvation is wholly by God’s mercy, and no one has a claim on him.

And the chapter closes by returning to faith. Gentiles who did not pursue righteousness attained it by faith; Israel pursued it by works and stumbled over the stone. Whoever believes in him will not be put to shame.

Do not use this chapter as a place to argue. Use it as a place to worship. If you are saved, it is because God had mercy on you.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 21:12 and 25:23 are the stories of Isaac and Jacob. Exodus 9:16, 33:19 and 4 to 14 tell of Pharaoh and Moses. Malachi 1:2-3 is quoted in verse 13. Isaiah 29:16 and Jeremiah 18:1-6 are the potter and the clay. Hosea 1:10 and 2:23 are quoted in verses 25 to 26. Isaiah 8:14 and 28:16 speak of the stone. Ephesians 1:4-5 and 2:8-9 speak of choice and grace. 1 Peter 2:4-10 says Christ is the cornerstone. John 6:37-44 teaches that the Father draws people. 2 Peter 3:9 says God is patient, not wishing that any should perish.

STEP 6

Application

Let this chapter humble you rather than divide you. Thank God for his mercy to you, which you did not earn.

Pray for people of Jewish background, and for your friends who do not believe, with the kind of anguish Paul had.

Ask whether you question God's right to rule. Where do you answer back?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you were not beloved and he called you beloved.

Tell him what you cannot understand about his choosing, and trust him.

Ask him to make you humble.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 107

“Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved.”

ROMANS 10:9

DAY 744 · WEEK 107

Romans 10:1-11:36

Faith from hearing; the mystery of Israel; doxology

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 10:1-11:36. This is a long reading, so take it in two parts: chapter 10 on faith that comes from hearing, and chapter 11 on God's plan for Israel and the Gentiles. End with the doxology in 11:33-36.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 9 stressed God's sovereign choice. Chapter 10 emphasizes human responsibility: Israel's problem is that they did not submit to God's righteousness, and the message is open to all who call. Chapter 11 asks the question that remains: has God rejected his people? Paul's answer reveals a mystery of God's plan across history, and it ends with one of the great praise passages in Scripture.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes" (10:4).
2. "Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved" (10:9).
3. "So faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ" (10:17).
4. "I ask, then, has God rejected his people? By no means!" (11:1).
5. "So too at the present time there is a remnant, chosen by grace" (11:5).
6. "And in this way all Israel will be saved" (11:26).
7. "Oh, the depth of the riches and wisdom and knowledge of God! How unsearchable are his judgments and how inscrutable his ways!" (11:33).

8 “For from him and through him and to him are all things. To him be glory forever. Amen” (11:36).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with prayer: “Brothers, my heart’s desire and prayer to God for them is that they may be saved.” He admits they have zeal for God, but not according to knowledge. Being ignorant of the righteousness of God, and seeking to establish their own, they did not submit. “For Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes.” The word “end” can mean goal or termination. Probably both: Christ is the goal toward which the law pointed, and its termination as a way of righteousness.

The message of faith is near: “The word is near you, in your mouth and in your heart.” And the heart of it: “If you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved. For with the heart one believes and is justified, and with the mouth one confesses and is saved.” The confession is “Jesus is Lord,” the earliest creed, and it is joined with belief in the resurrection. It is for everyone: “There is no distinction between Jew and Greek; for the same Lord is Lord of all, bestowing his riches on all who call on him. For everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.”

Then the chain of missions: “How then will they call on him in whom they have not believed? And how are they to believe in him of whom they have never heard? And how are they to hear without someone preaching? And how are they to preach unless they are sent? As it is written, How beautiful are the feet of those who preach the good news!” This passage has sent generations of missionaries. “So faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ.” Israel has heard but not obeyed. God has held out his hands to a disobedient and contrary people.

In chapter 11, Paul asks: has God rejected his people? “By no means! For I myself am an Israelite.” God has not rejected the people whom he foreknew. There is a remnant, chosen by grace: like the seven thousand in Elijah’s day. Others were hardened, but their stumbling has meant salvation for the Gentiles, to make Israel jealous.

Paul warns the Gentile believers with the picture of the olive tree. Branches were broken off because of unbelief, and wild olive branches (Gentiles) were grafted in. “Remember it is not you who support the root, but the root that supports you.” Do not be arrogant. And the broken-off branches can be grafted in again if they do not continue in unbelief.

Then the mystery: “A partial hardening has come upon Israel, until the fullness of the Gentiles has come in. And in this way all Israel will be saved.” Christians disagree about what “all Israel” means. Some think it refers to the whole elect people of God, Jew and Gentile

together. Others think it means the ethnic nation of Israel, who will turn to Christ in large numbers before or at the end. Others hold that it means the elect of Israel throughout history. All agree that God's gifts and calling are irrevocable, that he will be faithful to his promises, and that salvation for both Jew and Gentile comes only through faith in Christ.

The long argument ends not with a conclusion but with praise. "Oh, the depth of the riches and wisdom and knowledge of God! How unsearchable are his judgments and how inscrutable his ways! For who has known the mind of the Lord, or who has been his counselor? Or who has given a gift to him that he might be repaid? For from him and through him and to him are all things. To him be glory forever. Amen." When theology reaches its limit, it turns to worship.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 30:11-14 is quoted in 10:6-8. Joel 2:32 is quoted in verse 13. Isaiah 52:7 is quoted in verse 15. Isaiah 53:1 is quoted in verse 16. Deuteronomy 32:21 and Isaiah 65:1-2 are quoted in 10:19-21. 1 Kings 19:10-18 is the story of the seven thousand. Jeremiah 11:16-17 and Hosea 14:6 use the olive tree. Ephesians 2:11-22 speaks of Jew and Gentile made one. Galatians 6:16 mentions the Israel of God. Isaiah 40:13 is quoted in 11:34. Job 41:11 is quoted in verse 35. Revelation 7:9-10 pictures the worshiping multitude.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Romans 10:9 and share it with someone this week.

Pray for someone to be sent to those who have not heard. Consider how you can support missions.

Let the doxology in 11:33-36 be your prayer after a difficult question.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess Jesus as Lord with your mouth and tell him you believe God raised him.
- Pray for someone to hear and believe.
- Praise God for the depth of his wisdom.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 107

“Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved.”

ROMANS 10:9

DAY 745 · WEEK 107

Psalm 19:1-6

The heavens declare, creation's speech

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 19:1-6. Paul quotes verse 4 in Romans 10:18. Read these six verses as a picture of creation's wordless sermon, and think about why Paul says it is not enough.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 19 is a psalm of David in two parts. Verses 1 to 6 celebrate God's revelation in creation, and verses 7 to 14 celebrate his revelation in the law. C. S. Lewis called it among the greatest poems in the Psalter. In Romans 10, Paul has just asked, "Have they not heard?" and answers with verse 4 of this psalm: their voice has gone out to all the earth. Today we read the creation half in light of Romans.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork" (v. 1).
2. "Day to day pours out speech, and night to night reveals knowledge" (v. 2).
3. "There is no speech, nor are there words, whose voice is not heard" (v. 3).
4. "Their voice goes out through all the earth, and their words to the end of the world" (v. 4).
5. "In them he has set a tent for the sun" (v. 4).
6. "Which comes out like a bridegroom leaving his chamber" (v. 5).
7. "And, like a strong man, runs its course with joy" (v. 5).
8. "And there is nothing hidden from its heat" (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a grand claim: “The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork.” Creation is a witness. The verbs, declare, proclaim, pour out speech, reveal knowledge, are all verbs of speaking. Day after day, night after night, creation preaches. The sky is God’s billboard, and its message is his glory.

Yet verse 3 adds a paradox: “There is no speech, nor are there words, whose voice is not heard.” The sermon has no words, and yet its voice goes out through all the earth. The message is universal. This is why Paul says in Romans 1:20 that no one has an excuse: God’s eternal power and divine nature have been clearly perceived in the things that have been made. Look up at the stars and you see something of the majesty of the one who made them.

The second half of this section uses the sun as an example. God has set a tent for the sun, and it comes out “like a bridegroom leaving his chamber, and, like a strong man, runs its course with joy.” Its circuit goes from one end of the heavens to the other, and nothing is hidden from its heat. The sun is a great picture of a creature that obeys its Maker: radiant, joyful, regular. It is also a picture of the reach of God’s revelation.

Paul quotes verse 4 in Romans 10:18, but notice how. He has argued that faith comes from hearing the word of Christ. He asks, “Have they not heard?” and answers, “Indeed they have, for their voice has gone out to all the earth, and their words to the ends of the world.” Some interpreters think Paul is using the language of Psalm 19 to describe the reach of the gospel preached by the apostles, as the sun’s light reaches everywhere. Others think he is saying that the witness of creation alone leaves everyone accountable. Either way, the point is that general revelation cannot save. Creation shows God’s glory, but only the gospel shows how sinners can be made right with him. That is why the psalm turns, in verse 7, to the law of the LORD, which is perfect, reviving the soul.

Next time you look at the sky, let it point to its maker. Then open your Bible and learn the rest of the story.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 8 and Psalm 104 also celebrate creation. Job 38 to 41 is God’s speech from the whirlwind. Isaiah 40:26 invites us to lift up our eyes and see who created these. Romans 1:19-20 and 10:18 draw from this psalm. Acts 14:17 and 17:24-28 speak of God’s witness in nature. Colossians 1:23 speaks of the gospel proclaimed in all creation. John 1:1-5 speaks of the Word through whom all things were made. Revelation 21:23 says the city has no need of sun or moon, for the Lamb is its light.

STEP 6

Application

Go outside today and look at the sky, day or night. Let it declare the glory of God to you.

Thank God for the sun, which rises each day on his command.

Pray for someone who has only creation's witness and has never heard the gospel.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the speech of the heavens.

Ask him to open your ears to hear it.

Tell him where you have been deaf.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 107

"Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved."

ROMANS 10:9

DAY 746 · WEEK 107

Psalm 116

I will call on the name of the LORD

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Psalm · 19 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 116. Romans 10:13 says that everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved. This psalm is a testimony of someone who did exactly that. Notice the movement from near-death to thanksgiving.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 116 is a song of thanksgiving by someone who has been rescued from death. It is part of the Hallel (Psalms 113 to 118) that Jews sang at Passover. On the night before he was crucified, Jesus and his disciples would have sung these psalms after the supper (Matthew 26:30). So these words were in the air in the upper room. The phrase "call on the name of the LORD" appears four times and links to Romans 10.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I love the LORD, because he has heard my voice and my pleas for mercy" (v. 1).
2. "The snares of death encompassed me; the pangs of Sheol laid hold on me; I suffered distress and anguish" (v. 3).
3. "Then I called on the name of the LORD: O LORD, I pray, deliver my soul!" (v. 4).
4. "Gracious is the LORD, and righteous; our God is merciful" (v. 5).
5. "For you have delivered my soul from death, my eyes from tears, my feet from stumbling" (v. 8).
6. "What shall I render to the LORD for all his benefits to me?" (v. 12).
7. "I will lift up the cup of salvation and call on the name of the LORD" (v. 13).
8. "Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of his saints" (v. 15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts with love: “I love the LORD, because he has heard my voice.” Gratitude for answered prayer produces love. Because God inclined his ear, the psalmist says, “I will call on him as long as I live.” It is a lifelong promise.

Then he tells the story. The snares of death surrounded him, the pangs of Sheol laid hold of him. We do not know the illness or danger, but it was severe. “Then I called on the name of the LORD: O LORD, I pray, deliver my soul!” It is a short prayer, the prayer of someone with no time for long speeches. And God answered. Notice what the psalmist says about God’s character: gracious, righteous, merciful, one who preserves the simple. “When I was brought low, he saved me.” The simple are not fools but those who depend on God rather than on their own cleverness.

The psalmist addresses his own soul: “Return, O my soul, to your rest, for the LORD has dealt bountifully with you.” Rest follows rescue. He has been delivered from death, tears, and stumbling, and he resolves to walk before the LORD in the land of the living.

Then the question that fits all Christians: “What shall I render to the LORD for all his benefits to me?” How can we repay God? We can’t. The answer is surprising: “I will lift up the cup of salvation and call on the name of the LORD.” The way to respond to a gift is to receive it again, gladly. The cup of salvation recalls the cup of the Passover. For Christians, it recalls the cup that Jesus gave his disciples, the new covenant in his blood. We do not repay God; we take the cup and thank him.

Verse 15 says, “Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of his saints.” For the believer, death is not meaningless. God notices and values the death of each one who belongs to him. The psalmist is also a servant, the son of God’s maidservant, whose chains the LORD has loosed. He promises to pay his vows in the presence of all the people, in the courts of the house of the LORD. Thanksgiving is public.

This is a good psalm to pray after a hard season. And when we read it as Jesus’ hymn, we see that on the night he was betrayed he sang of the cup of salvation, then went out to drink the cup of suffering. The LORD would deliver his soul from death, not by sparing him but by raising him.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 10:13 and Joel 2:32 speak of calling on the name of the LORD. Psalm 113 to 118 are the Hallel. Matthew 26:27-30 and Luke 22:17-20 describe the cup and the hymn. 1 Corinthians 10:16 and 11:25 speak of the cup of blessing. Psalm 56:12-13 also gives thanks for deliverance.

Psalm 91 speaks of refuge and rescue. Philippians 1:21-23 speaks of death as gain. Hebrews 5:7 says Jesus offered up prayers with loud cries to him who was able to save him from death. Revelation 14:13 says blessed are the dead who die in the Lord.

STEP 6

Application

Pray the short prayer of verse 4 for a situation today: O LORD, I pray, deliver my soul.

Ask what you will render to the LORD for his benefits. Take the cup of salvation by thanking him aloud for specific gifts.

Next time you take the Lord's Supper, remember that Jesus sang this psalm.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you love him because he hears.
- Thank him for saving you from death.
- Ask him what you can render for all his benefits.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 107

"Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved."

ROMANS 10:9

DAY 747 · WEEK 107

Psalm 117

Praise the LORD, all nations

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Psalm · 2 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 117, the shortest chapter in the Bible. Paul quotes it in Romans 15:11 at the climax of his argument that the gospel unites Jew and Gentile. You have read this psalm before. Read it today as part of Paul's closing argument in Romans.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 117 sits at the center of the Bible in the Hebrew-English Bible's order of chapters, at the end of the Hallel's first half. In just two verses it calls all nations to praise the LORD. Paul will use it in Romans 15 as the proof text that the Gentiles were always meant to glorify God for his mercy. Reading it in the middle of Romans, as we approach the practical chapters, we see the goal of the letter: a united people of Jew and Gentile worshiping one God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD, all nations!" (v. 1).
2. "Extol him, all peoples!" (v. 1).
3. "For great is his steadfast love" (v. 2).
4. "Toward us" (v. 2).
5. "The faithfulness of the LORD" (v. 2).
6. "Endures forever" (v. 2).
7. "Praise the LORD!" (v. 2).
8. "All peoples" (v. 1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm contains one command and one reason. The command: “Praise the LORD, all nations! Extol him, all peoples!” The reason: “For great is his steadfast love toward us, and the faithfulness of the LORD endures forever.” Notice again that the reason for the nations to praise is God’s love “toward us,” toward Israel. This is the logic of Romans 9 to 11. God’s faithfulness to Israel is the means by which the nations learn to praise.

In Romans 15:8-9, Paul explains: “Christ became a servant to the circumcised to show God’s truthfulness, in order to confirm the promises given to the patriarchs, and in order that the Gentiles might glorify God for his mercy.” Two parts of one plan: Christ confirms the promises to Israel (God’s truthfulness), and the Gentiles glorify God for his mercy. Then Paul gathers four Old Testament quotations, from the Psalms, Deuteronomy, the Psalms again, and Isaiah, to prove that the Gentiles’ praise was always intended. Psalm 117:1 is the third of these: “Praise the Lord, all you Gentiles, and let all the peoples extol him.”

Notice how Psalm 117 brings together the two terms that have occupied us in Romans. “Steadfast love” is the word hesed, covenant mercy. “Faithfulness” is truth, reliability. These are God’s grace and truth, the two gifts that came through Jesus Christ (John 1:17). On the cross, steadfast love and faithfulness met. The nations are invited to praise because they, too, can now rest on God’s mercy.

The psalm is brief because the message is simple: the God of Israel is the God of all, and all should praise him. Short as it is, it carries the entire hope of the Bible. The scattered peoples of Babel will be brought together before the throne. Revelation 7:9 pictures “a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages” praising God. This psalm is a first sketch of that scene.

Make it your own. When you praise the LORD in church, remember that you are joining a chorus drawn from every tribe, and the psalm is calling more to join.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 15:8-12 quotes this psalm with Psalm 18:49, Deuteronomy 32:43, and Isaiah 11:10. Genesis 12:3 promised blessing to all families of the earth. Psalm 67 and Psalm 96 also call the nations to praise. Isaiah 49:6 speaks of salvation to the end of the earth. John 1:17 says grace and truth came through Jesus Christ. Ephesians 2:11-22 says Jew and Gentile are one new man. Revelation 5:9 and 7:9-10 picture the nations in worship.

STEP 6

Application

Say the psalm aloud as a prayer. It takes about ten seconds.

Pray for the nations by name. Pick three countries and pray that they would praise the LORD.

Thank God that you are part of the people he has gathered from all the nations.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise the LORD with all the nations.

Thank him that Christ confirmed his promise to include them.

Pray for the nations to know him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 107

"Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved."

ROMANS 10:9

DAY 748 · WEEK 107

Romans 12:1-13:14

Living sacrifice; love; governing authorities

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 12:1-13:14. Paul turns from doctrine to its practical results. Notice the word “therefore” that begins chapter 12, the call to a living sacrifice, the community ethics, and the instructions on government and love.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first eleven chapters of Romans explain what God has done. Chapter 12 begins, “I appeal to you therefore, brothers, by the mercies of God.” The mercies of God, everything described in chapters 1 to 11, are the basis for all Christian living. Doctrine leads to doxology (11:33-36) and then to duty. What follows is a practical guide for the believer’s life in the church, in the world, and under the government.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “I appeal to you therefore, brothers, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God, which is your spiritual worship” (12:1).
2. “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind” (12:2).
3. “So we, though many, are one body in Christ, and individually members one of another” (12:5).
4. “Let love be genuine. Abhor what is evil; hold fast to what is good” (12:9).
5. “Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good” (12:21).
6. “Let every person be subject to the governing authorities. For there is no authority except from God, and those that exist have been instituted by God” (13:1).

7. “Owe no one anything, except to love each other, for the one who loves another has fulfilled the law” (13:8).

8. “But put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make no provision for the flesh, to gratify its desires” (13:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“By the mercies of God.” The appeal is not based on threats or fear, but on mercy. Because God has saved us, we offer ourselves. “Present your bodies as a living sacrifice.” In the Old Testament, sacrifices were killed. Now we are living sacrifices, daily offering everything to God: hands, feet, time, money, vocation. This is “your spiritual worship” (or “reasonable service”). Worship is not only singing on Sunday; it is the whole of life offered to God.

“Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind.” The world presses us into its mold, and the Spirit transforms us from within. As the mind is renewed by the word of God, we are able to discern God’s will, “what is good and acceptable and perfect.”

Paul next calls for humility and sober judgment. We are one body with many members, and each has gifts: prophecy, serving, teaching, exhorting, giving, leading, mercy. Each is to be used with the right attitude: generosity, zeal, cheerfulness. Then follows a series of short commands on love in action, verses 9 to 21: genuine love, brotherly affection, outdoing one another in showing honor, not slothful in zeal, fervent in spirit, serving the Lord, rejoicing in hope, patient in tribulation, constant in prayer, contributing to saints’ needs, practicing hospitality. “Bless those who persecute you; bless and do not curse them. Rejoice with those who rejoice, weep with those who weep. Live in harmony with one another.” “Never avenge yourselves, but leave it to the wrath of God.” And the climax: “If your enemy is hungry, feed him; if he is thirsty, give him something to drink… Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good.”

Chapter 13 opens with a subject that has caused much discussion: governing authorities. “Let every person be subject to the governing authorities. For there is no authority except from God.” Government is a gift of God for restraining evil and promoting good. Christians should pay taxes and give respect where it is due. Paul was writing under Nero. Most interpreters note that this does not mean unlimited obedience: Peter and John said, “We must obey God rather than men” (Acts 5:29). When governments command what God forbids, believers must obey God. But the default is respect and cooperation.

Then Paul returns to love. “Owe no one anything, except to love each other, for the one who loves another has fulfilled the law.” Love sums up the commandments. He closes with urgency: “The night is far gone; the day is at hand.” The return of Christ is nearer than when we first believed. So “cast off the works of darkness and put on the armor of light.” The last command is perhaps the best summary of sanctification: “Put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make no provision for the flesh, to gratify its desires.” This was the verse that Augustine read in the garden, and which led to his conversion.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 1 and Hebrews 13:15-16 speak of sacrifice. Ephesians 4:1-16 and 1 Corinthians 12 speak of the body and gifts. Proverbs 25:21-22 is quoted in verse 20. Deuteronomy 32:35 is cited in verse 19. 1 Peter 2:13-17 and Titus 3:1-2 speak of government. Mark 12:17 says to render to Caesar. Acts 5:29 and Daniel 3 and 6 show the limits of obedience. Revelation 13 is another view of the state. Matthew 22:37-40 and Galatians 5:14 say love fulfills the law. Ephesians 6:10-18 speaks of armor.

STEP 6

Application

Offer your body as a living sacrifice today. Choose one specific thing: your schedule, a talent, a habit.

Renew your mind by reading Scripture first, before the news.

Look for an enemy or difficult person to bless, and do something kind.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Present your body to God as a living sacrifice, and say what that means today.
- Ask him to renew your mind.
- Ask him to help you love without pretense.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 107

“Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved.”

ROMANS 10:9

DAY 749 · WEEK 107

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Romans 10:9 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved."

ROMANS 10:9

REST

Meditation

This verse is among the clearest statements in the New Testament of what it means to be saved.

"If you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord." The earliest Christian creed is three words: Jesus is Lord. In the Greek Old Testament, "Lord" (kyrios) was the word for the name of God. To say "Jesus is Lord" is to say that Jesus shares the identity of the LORD. It is also a statement of allegiance: he is my master. In a world where Caesar was called lord, it was a dangerous confession.

"And believe in your heart." The faith that saves is not just agreement; it comes from the heart, the center of the person. It is trust, not just knowledge.

“That God raised him from the dead.” The resurrection is the center of the faith. It proves that Jesus is who he said he was, that his death was accepted, and that death has been defeated.

“You will be saved.” The promise is sure. Saved from the wrath, from sin’s power, and ultimately from death.

Notice that the verse joins heart and mouth. True faith naturally speaks. And verse 13 adds that it is open to all: everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.

When you doubt whether you are really saved, return to this verse and ask: do I confess that Jesus is Lord, and do I believe that God raised him from the dead? If so, you have the promise of God.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw the final stretch of Paul’s argument and the beginning of its application. In Romans 9, Paul grieved over Israel and taught that God’s word has not failed, because God’s purposes work by mercy and election, not by physical descent. Chapter 10 gave the message of faith: confess that Jesus is Lord, believe that God raised him from the dead, and call on his name, and faith comes from hearing the word of Christ. Chapter 11 asked whether God has rejected Israel and answered with the remnant, the olive tree, and the mystery of “all Israel,” ending in the doxology: from him and through him and to him are all things. Three psalms accompanied the reading: Psalm 19 on creation’s voice that goes out to all the earth, Psalm 116 on calling on the name of the LORD, and Psalm 117 on the nations praising. Romans 12 and 13 began the practical section, calling believers to offer themselves as a living sacrifice and to overcome evil with good.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul had great sorrow and unceasing anguish for those who did not believe. Who in your life do you carry that kind of burden for? What is one concrete thing you will do to pray for or reach out to them?

Romans 10:9 says to confess Jesus is Lord and believe that God raised him from the dead. What does it mean in daily life for Jesus to be your Lord, and not only your Savior?

Romans 12:1 says to present your whole self as a living sacrifice because of God's mercies. What part of your life is hardest to hand over? What mercy of God can you remember as you do so?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess Jesus as Lord, and thank him for raising him from the dead.

Thank him for the promise of salvation.

Rest in him.

DAY 750 · WEEK 108

Romans 14:1-15:13

The strong and the weak; welcome one another

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 36 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 14:1-15:13. Paul addresses a practical problem in the Roman church: believers who disagree about food and holy days. Notice how Paul handles disagreements on secondary matters, and how he grounds the call to welcome in the example of Christ.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Roman church included Jews and Gentiles. Some Jewish believers continued to observe food laws and holy days; some Gentile believers did not. Each group tended to look down on the other. Paul does not tell them to ignore the issue. He gives guidance for how to live together when Christians disagree on matters that Scripture does not settle. This section is very relevant to the church today.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "As for the one who is weak in faith, welcome him, but not to quarrel over opinions" (14:1).
2. "Each one should be fully convinced in his own mind" (14:5).
3. "For if we live, we live to the Lord, and if we die, we die to the Lord. So then, whether we live or whether we die, we are the Lord's" (14:8).
4. "For the kingdom of God is not a matter of eating and drinking but of righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit" (14:17).
5. "So then let us pursue what makes for peace and for mutual upbuilding" (14:19).

6. “We who are strong have an obligation to bear with the failings of the weak, and not to please ourselves” (15:1).

7. “For whatever was written in former days was written for our instruction, that through endurance and through the encouragement of the Scriptures we might have hope” (15:4).

8. “Therefore welcome one another as Christ has welcomed you, for the glory of God” (15:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul identifies two groups. The “weak in faith” are those whose consciences are bound on matters like eating only vegetables or keeping special days. The “strong” are those who understand that all foods are clean and every day belongs to the Lord. The surprise is that Paul sides with the strong in belief (14:14, “I am persuaded in the Lord Jesus that nothing is unclean in itself”) but demands that the strong treat the weak with love.

The first rule: “Welcome him.” Do not despise or pass judgment. The one who eats must not despise the one who abstains, and the one who abstains must not pass judgment on the one who eats, for God has welcomed him. “Who are you to pass judgment on the servant of another? It is before his own master that he stands or falls.” Each should be fully convinced in his own mind, acting from faith: “Whatever does not proceed from faith is sin.”

The ground for this tolerance is Christ’s lordship: “None of us lives to himself, and none of us dies to himself. For if we live, we live to the Lord, and if we die, we die to the Lord. So then, whether we live or whether we die, we are the Lord’s. For to this end Christ died and lived again, that he might be Lord both of the dead and of the living.” We will all stand before God’s judgment seat, and each will give an account of himself. That should end our habit of judging others.

The second rule: do not cause others to stumble. “It is good not to eat meat or drink wine or do anything that causes your brother to stumble.” Freedom must be used with love. “The kingdom of God is not a matter of eating and drinking but of righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit.” We should pursue peace and upbuilding. “Do not, for the sake of food, destroy the work of God.”

Chapter 15 gives the pattern: Christ himself. “We who are strong have an obligation to bear with the failings of the weak, and not to please ourselves… For Christ did not please himself.” The example of Christ leads Paul to speak of the Scriptures: written for our instruction, that through endurance and encouragement we might have hope. And he prays for a church with one voice: “May the God of endurance and encouragement grant you to live in such harmony

with one another, in accord with Christ Jesus, that together you may with one voice glorify the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ." The command is then repeated and grounded: "Welcome one another as Christ has welcomed you, for the glory of God." Christ became a servant to the circumcised to confirm the promises, and so that the Gentiles might glorify God for his mercy.

This does not mean that everything is a matter of opinion. Paul is clear on the gospel, on sin, and on Christ's resurrection. The category of disputable matters includes issues the Bible does not settle. Wise Christians distinguish essentials, convictions, and preferences. On essentials, unity; on disputable matters, liberty; and in all things, love.

Paul closes with a blessing: "May the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, so that by the power of the Holy Spirit you may abound in hope."

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 11 gives the food laws. Mark 7:14-23 shows Jesus declaring all foods clean. Acts 10 shows Peter's vision. Colossians 2:16-23 deals with food and festival. 1 Corinthians 8 and 10:23-33 deal with food offered to idols. Galatians 5:13-15 speaks of freedom and love. Philippians 2:1-11 calls for the mind of Christ. Psalm 69:9 is quoted in 15:3. Ephesians 4:1-6 speaks of the unity of the Spirit. Psalm 18:49, Deuteronomy 32:43, Psalm 117:1, and Isaiah 11:10 are quoted in 15:9-12. John 17:20-23 is Jesus' prayer for unity.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a fellow Christian you disagree with on a disputable matter. Welcome them in a concrete way this week.

Ask what freedoms you might lay aside for the sake of someone else's conscience.

Memorize Romans 15:7 and pray it for your church.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for welcoming you when you were far off.

Ask him to help you welcome someone he has welcomed.

Ask him to give you the mind of Christ toward those who differ.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 108

"But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons."

GALATIANS 4:4-5

DAY 751 · WEEK 108

Romans 15:14-16:27

Paul's plans; greetings; the doxology

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 15:14-16:27. Paul explains his ministry and plans, then sends a long list of greetings. Notice the names, especially the women and the many co-workers, and the closing doxology.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul closes his letter by looking ahead. He has preached the gospel from Jerusalem to Illyricum, and now he plans to go to Spain, stopping in Rome on the way. First he must take the collection to Jerusalem. Chapter 16 reads like a list of names, but it is a window into the early church: women and men, slaves and free, Jews and Gentiles, house churches all over Rome. Every name stands for a real life changed by the gospel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "To be a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles in the priestly service of the gospel of God" (15:16).
2. "And thus I make it my ambition to preach the gospel, not where Christ has already been named" (15:20).
3. "I hope to see you in passing as I go to Spain" (15:24).
4. "I commend to you our sister Phoebe, a servant of the church at Cenchreae" (16:1).
5. "Greet Prisca and Aquila, my fellow workers in Christ Jesus" (16:3).
6. "I appeal to you, brothers, to watch out for those who cause divisions and create obstacles contrary to the doctrine that you have been taught" (16:17).
7. "The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet" (16:20).

8 “To the only wise God be glory forevermore through Jesus Christ! Amen” (16:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with a compliment. He is satisfied that the Romans are full of goodness, filled with all knowledge, and able to instruct one another. Yet he has written boldly, as a reminder. He describes his ministry in priestly terms: he is “a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles in the priestly service of the gospel of God, so that the offering of the Gentiles may be acceptable, sanctified by the Holy Spirit.” The Gentiles, brought to faith, are his offering to God.

His ambition is to preach where Christ has not been named. Now that this work in the eastern Mediterranean is complete, he looks west to Spain. He asks the Romans to help him on his journey. Before he goes, he must take the collection from Macedonia and Achaia to the poor saints in Jerusalem, a sign of unity between Gentile and Jewish believers. “I appeal to you, brothers… to strive together with me in your prayers to God on my behalf, that I may be delivered from the unbelievers in Judea.” Paul would indeed be arrested in Jerusalem, as we read in Acts, and reach Rome as a prisoner.

Chapter 16 begins with Phoebe, a servant (or deacon) of the church at Cenchreae, who very likely carried the letter to Rome. Paul calls her a “patron of many.” Next are Prisca and Aquila, who risked their necks for Paul and host a church in their house. Epaenetus, Mary, Andronicus and Junia, Ampliatus, Urbanus, Stachys, Apelles, and many others follow. Paul names about thirty people, with warm words: “beloved,” “fellow worker,” “approved in Christ,” “workers in the Lord.” Women feature prominently. The letter reminds us that the gospel is carried by ordinary people with extraordinary faithfulness. Christians differ about roles of women in church leadership, but all should honor the labor of these women.

Right in the middle comes a warning: “I appeal to you, brothers, to watch out for those who cause divisions and create obstacles contrary to the doctrine that you have been taught; avoid them. For such persons do not serve our Lord Christ, but their own appetites.” Doctrine matters, and unity is not unity at any price. But the promise comes: “The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet.” This echoes Genesis 3:15.

Tertius, who wrote down the letter, adds his own greeting: “I Tertius, who wrote this letter, greet you in the Lord.” It is a delightful reminder that this great letter was dictated and written by a human scribe.

Then the final doxology. “Now to him who is able to strengthen you according to my gospel and the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery that was kept secret for long ages but has now been disclosed and through the prophetic writings has been

made known to all nations, according to the command of the eternal God, to bring about the obedience of faith, to the only wise God be glory forevermore through Jesus Christ! Amen." The letter ends where it began: with the gospel, the Scriptures, the obedience of faith, and all nations. The mystery of the ages is revealed in Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 18:1-3, 18-26 tell of Prisca and Aquila. Acts 20:1-3 shows Paul at Corinth when he wrote. Acts 21 to 28 tell what happened after the collection. 2 Corinthians 8 to 9 describe the collection. Genesis 3:15 promises the crushing of the serpent. Colossians 1:25-27 and Ephesians 3:1-13 speak of the mystery now revealed. 1 Corinthians 15:58 says our labor is not in vain. Philippians 2:25-30 speaks of Epaphroditus. 3 John and Titus 3:9-11 also warn about division.

STEP 6

Application

Write down the names of five people who have served you in the faith. Thank at least one of them this week.

Ask what your ambition is. Is there a place where Christ has not been named that God is calling you to?

Pray the last doxology as your own.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for those who have carried the gospel to you.
- Ask him to make you a faithful servant of his church.
- Praise him as the only wise God.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 108

“But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons.”

GALATIANS 4:4-5

DAY 752 · WEEK 108

Review and Reflection

Unit 20 review, The New Covenant Explained, Romans

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
>
> ROMANS 8:1

REST

Meditation

Paul wrote this verse after the cry of Romans 7:24, "Wretched man that I am!" It is the hinge of the letter, where the argument of chapters 1 to 7 reaches its destination.

"There is therefore." This word connects to everything before it. Because of the justification in chapters 3 to 5 and the union with Christ in chapter 6, there is no condemnation. It is a conclusion, not a hope.

"Now." Not "someday" or "maybe." The verdict is already given. It is a present reality, not something to be earned.

"No condemnation." Not "less condemnation" or "reduced." None. Condemnation means the sentence of a judge. For those who believe, the sentence has been carried out on Christ.

"For those who are in Christ Jesus." This is the condition, and it is not a work. It is a place: in Christ. Those who are united to him by faith share his standing.

When your conscience accuses you, when Satan points to your sin, when you remember what you have done, say this verse. The charge against you has been answered. The sentence has been served. You are in Christ.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

You have read Paul's letter to the Romans, the fullest explanation of the gospel in the Bible. It began with the theme, that the gospel is the power of God for salvation, and the righteousness of God is revealed from faith for faith. Paul showed that the whole world is guilty: Gentiles who suppress the truth, and Jews and moralists who judge others and do the same. In a doctrinal pause you thought about the wrath of God as his holy opposition to evil. Then came the great turn: the righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the law, and sinners are justified by grace through faith in Jesus, whom God put forward as a propitiation. You studied justification by faith alone and Abraham as the model of faith. Three psalms of repentance, 32, 130, and 143, gave the heart's response. Romans 5 traced peace with God and the two heads, Adam and Christ. A doctrinal pause on union with Christ showed that believers died and rose with him. Chapters 6 and 7 dealt with slavery to sin, the holiness of the law, and the struggle within, and a pause on sanctification showed that God works in us both to will and to work. Romans 8 gave the summit: no condemnation, the Spirit of adoption, the groaning of creation, and the love of God from which nothing can separate us. Chapters 9 to 11 treated God's faithfulness to Israel, his sovereign mercy, the call to confess Jesus as Lord, and the doxology of the depth of the riches and wisdom of God. The Psalms 19, 116, and 117 sang the reach of the gospel to all nations. Chapters 12 to 16 turned doctrine into life: the living sacrifice, the renewed mind, love, government, welcome across differences, and a list of names that shows the gospel carried by ordinary people.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does Paul mean by "the righteousness of God" in Romans 1:17?

Read Romans 1:16-17 and 3:21-26. Is the righteousness of God a quality he has, a gift he gives, or both? How does it connect to Habakkuk 2:4, "The righteous shall live by faith"?

What is justification by faith alone, and why does it matter?

Look at Romans 3:23-28 and 4:1-8. What does "counted as righteousness" mean? How is faith related to works, and what changes in the Christian life if you get this wrong?

What is the role of the Holy Spirit in the Christian life according to Romans 8?

Reread Romans 8:1-17 and 26-27. What does the Spirit do for the believer: freedom, life, adoption, assurance, help in prayer? How is he connected to the hope of resurrection?

How does Romans 9-11 address the question of God's faithfulness to Israel?

Consider Romans 9:6, 11:1-5, 11:17-26, and 11:29. How has God's word not failed? What do the remnant, the olive tree, and the mystery teach about Jew and Gentile in God's plan?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the gospel Romans explains.

Thank him that you are justified by faith.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 21 · DAYS 753-784

Law, Gospel and Church Life: Galatians, Corinthians

Galatians, 1-2 Corinthians

The sufficiency of grace. The cross as the center of everything.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me."

GALATIANS 2:20

Psalms 33, 62, 111, 112, and 133 on trust, generosity, and unity.

UNIT 21

In this unit

WEEK 108

753	Galatians 1:1-2:21	*Reading*
754	Romans 8:14-17; Galatians 4:1-7; 1 John 3:1-3	*Doctrine*
755	Galatians 3:1-4:31	*Reading*
756	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 109

757	Galatians 5:1-6:18	*Reading*
758	1 Corinthians 1:1-2:16	*Reading*
759	1 Corinthians 3:1-4:21	*Reading*
760	Psalm 33	*Psalm*
761	Psalm 62	*Psalm*
762	1 Corinthians 5:1-7:40	*Reading*
763	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 110

764	1 Corinthians 8:1-10:33	*Reading*
765	1 Corinthians 11:17-34; Luke 22:14-20; Matthew 26:26-29	*Doctrine*
766	1 Corinthians 11:1-34	*Reading*
767	1 Corinthians 12:1-14:40	*Reading*
768	1 Corinthians 12:1-31; Romans 12:3-8; Ephesians 4:11-16	*Doctrine*
769	Psalm 111	*Psalm*
770	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 111

771	Psalm 112	*Psalm*
772	Psalm 133	*Psalm*
773	1 Corinthians 15:1-58	*Reading*
774	1 Corinthians 15:1-28; Matthew 28:1-10	*Doctrine*

775	1 Corinthians 15:35-58; Daniel 12:1-3; John 5:28-29	*Doctrine*
776	1 Corinthians 16:1-24	*Reading*
777	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 112

778	2 Corinthians 1:1-3:18	*Reading*
779	2 Corinthians 5:1-10; Philippians 1:21-24; Luke 23:39-43	*Doctrine*
780	2 Corinthians 4:1-5:21	*Reading*
781	2 Corinthians 6:1-9:15	*Reading*
782	2 Corinthians 10:1-13:14	*Reading*
783	Review and Reflection	*Review*
784	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 753 · WEEK 108

Galatians 1:1-2:21

No other gospel; Paul's apostleship; justification by faith

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 45 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Galatians 1:1-2:21. This is Paul's most urgent letter. Notice that he skips the usual thanksgiving and goes straight to alarm. Read his defense of the gospel and of his apostleship, and end with 2:15-21, the heart of the matter.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Galatians is probably Paul's earliest letter, written around AD 48 to 49 to churches he founded in the region of Galatia (in modern Turkey). After he left, teachers came who insisted that Gentile believers must be circumcised and keep the law of Moses to be truly part of God's people. Paul sees that this is not a minor disagreement but a different gospel. The letter is his passionate defense of salvation by grace through faith in Christ alone. It was Martin Luther's favorite letter, and he called it his "Katie von Bora."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Who gave himself for our sins to deliver us from the present evil age, according to the will of our God and Father" (1:4).
2. "I am astonished that you are so quickly deserting him who called you in the grace of Christ and are turning to a different gospel" (1:6).
3. "But even if we or an angel from heaven should preach to you a gospel contrary to the one we preached to you, let him be accursed" (1:8).
4. "For I did not receive it from any man, nor was I taught it, but I received it through a revelation of Jesus Christ" (1:12).
5. "I opposed him to his face, because he stood condemned" (2:11).

6. “Yet we know that a person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ” (2:16).
7. “I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me” (2:20).
8. “I do not nullify the grace of God, for if righteousness were through the law, then Christ died for no purpose” (2:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul opens by stressing that he is an apostle “not from men nor through man, but through Jesus Christ and God the Father, who raised him from the dead.” His authority and message come from Christ. Even his greeting contains the gospel: Christ “gave himself for our sins to deliver us from the present evil age.” Then, instead of a thanksgiving, he says, “I am astonished.” The Galatians are deserting the one who called them in grace. There is no other gospel, only some who trouble you and want to distort the gospel of Christ. He pronounces a curse on anyone, even an angel, who preaches a different gospel. This is strong language because the gospel is not negotiable.

He defends his own gospel by telling his story. He once persecuted the church violently and was advancing in Judaism beyond many of his peers. But God, who had set him apart from his mother’s womb, was pleased to reveal his Son to him. He did not consult with flesh and blood, but went to Arabia and returned to Damascus. Three years later he visited Peter in Jerusalem for fifteen days; he met James, the Lord’s brother. The churches of Judea glorified God because of him.

After fourteen years, he went again to Jerusalem with Barnabas and Titus, and laid before the leaders the gospel he preached among the Gentiles. The leaders added nothing to him. Titus, though a Greek, was not compelled to be circumcised. James, Cephas, and John gave Paul and Barnabas the right hand of fellowship, agreeing that Paul was to go to the Gentiles and they to the circumcised, asking only that they remember the poor.

Then the confrontation at Antioch. Peter had eaten with Gentile believers, but when certain men came from James, he drew back and separated himself, fearing the circumcision party. Even Barnabas was led astray. Paul opposed Peter to his face, because his conduct was not in step with the truth of the gospel. This is the principle: the gospel governs how we live together, and it applies even to apostles.

The center of the chapter is 2:15 to 21. “A person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ.” Paul says this three times in a single verse. Then the personal confession: “I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives

in me. And the life I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me." This is the verse of the unit. Christ's death is my death; his life is my life. And Paul concludes: to go back to the law is to say that Christ died for no purpose. The cross either is enough or it is nothing.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 1:16-17 and 3:21-31 explain the same gospel at greater length. Acts 9:1-30, 15:1-35, and 11:27-30 are the background. Genesis 12:3 and 15:6 stand behind chapter 3. Philippians 3:2-9 repeats the warning against confidence in the flesh. 2 Corinthians 11:4 speaks of a different gospel. 1 Timothy 1:15 shows the heart of the gospel. 1 Corinthians 15:1-11 gives its content. Ephesians 2:8-10 sums up salvation by grace.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Galatians 2:20. Say it each morning this week.

Ask whether you are adding anything to Christ as a requirement for acceptance with God or with his people.

Pray for courage to speak up as Paul did when the gospel is at stake.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the gospel of grace.

Ask him to keep you from any other gospel.

Thank Jesus for giving himself for your sins.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 108

"But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons."

GALATIANS 4:4-5

DAY 754 · WEEK 108

Romans 8:14-17; Galatians 4:1-7; 1 John 3:1-3

Adoption

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 8:14-17, Galatians 4:1-7, and 1 John 3:1-3. Today is a doctrinal pause on adoption. Notice who does the adopting, what the Spirit cries, and what the adopted child receives.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Adoption was a familiar practice in the Roman world. A wealthy family without a suitable heir could adopt a son, who then gained the full rights of the family name and inheritance. Paul uses this to explain what God has done for believers. We were not born children of God in the full covenant sense; we were slaves, and God brought us into his family at great cost. John, the apostle of love, marvels at the same fact.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “For all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God” (Romans 8:14).
2. “You have received the Spirit of adoption as sons, by whom we cry, Abba! Father!” (Romans 8:15).
3. “And if children, then heirs, heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ” (Romans 8:17).
4. “But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons” (Galatians 4:4-5).
5. “And because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, Abba! Father!” (Galatians 4:6).

6. “So you are no longer a slave, but a son, and if a son, then an heir through God” (Galatians 4:7).
7. “See what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God; and so we are” (1 John 3:1).
8. “Beloved, we are God’s children now” (1 John 3:2).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Adoption is the act of God by which he receives believers into his family as his sons and daughters, with all the rights and privileges that belong to children. It is one of the richest images of salvation. Justification answers the question, “How can I be declared right before the Judge?” Adoption answers the question, “How can I be welcomed by the Father?” The two go together. Justification gives us a legal standing; adoption gives us a family and a Father.

Notice the Trinity at work. The Father sends the Son “in the fullness of time” to redeem those under the law. The Son becomes man, born of woman, born under the law, so that he can redeem. The Spirit is sent into our hearts, and he teaches us to cry “Abba! Father!” The word Abba is the Aramaic word of a child to his father, an intimate word that Jesus himself used in Gethsemane (Mark 14:36). Through Christ we share his relationship with the Father.

Adoption has present and future dimensions. Now we are God’s children, and we have the Spirit, access to the Father, his discipline, his care, and his promises. But Paul also says we “wait eagerly for adoption as sons, the redemption of our bodies” (Romans 8:23). Our full inheritance, the resurrection and the new creation, is still to come. John says, “What we will be has not yet appeared; but we know that when he appears we will be like him.”

Adoption is the answer to many fears. The fear of rejection: God has chosen you. The fear of earning: a child does not earn his place. The fear of being alone: the Father is near. And the fear of failing: a child may fail, but remains a child. It also shapes our life together: if we have one Father, we are brothers and sisters. Christians who struggle with the idea of God as Father, because of a human father who failed them, can find that God is the Father they always needed.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Galatians 4 begins with an illustration. An heir, as long as he is a child, is no different from a slave, though he is the owner of everything. He is under guardians until the date set by his father. So we, when we were children, were enslaved to the elementary principles of the world. “But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son.” The timing was

God's. He sent his Son "born of woman, born under the law." The Son took on humanity and submitted to the law. The purpose: "to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons."

Then the Spirit: "And because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, Abba! Father!" The Spirit is the Spirit of the Son; when he lives in us, he leads us to pray as the Son prays. Prayer is the family voice. "So you are no longer a slave, but a son, and if a son, then an heir through God."

Romans 8 gives the same truth in the setting of suffering. The Spirit does not make us slaves again to fall back into fear, but sons. "The Spirit himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God, and if children, then heirs, heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with him in order that we may also be glorified with him." We share his sufferings now and his glory later.

1 John 3:1 sounds like a gasp of wonder: "See what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God; and so we are." The love is not just a feeling; it is something given, an action. And the "so we are" is a guarantee. The world does not recognize us, because it did not know him. But the hope is certain: when he appears, we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is. And "everyone who thus hopes in him purifies himself as he is pure." The hope of the family inheritance motivates holy living.

STEP 5

Connection

Mark 14:36 records Jesus praying "Abba, Father." Matthew 6:9 begins the Lord's Prayer with "Our Father." John 1:12-13 says to all who believed he gave the right to become children of God. Ephesians 1:5 speaks of predestination to adoption. Hebrews 12:5-11 speaks of the Father's discipline. Romans 8:23 and 9:4 speak of adoption. 2 Corinthians 6:18 quotes the promise "I will be a father to you." Luke 15:11-32 shows the Father's welcome. Revelation 21:7 says the one who conquers will have this heritage.

STEP 6

Application

Pray "Abba, Father" today and let yourself feel what it means.

If you struggle with the word "Father," tell God honestly. Ask him to show you what a true Father is.

Treat a fellow believer today as a brother or sister, not an acquaintance.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for sending his Son to redeem you so that you could be adopted.

Pray, “Abba, Father,” and tell him what it means.

Thank him that you are an heir.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 108

“But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons.”

GALATIANS 4:4-5

DAY 755 · WEEK 108

Galatians 3:1-4:31

The law as guardian; sons not slaves; Hagar and Sarah

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Galatians 3:1-4:31. This long reading is Paul's theological argument. Notice his use of Abraham and the promise, the purpose of the law, and the allegory of Hagar and Sarah. Pay special attention to 3:23-29.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has shown in chapters 1 and 2 that the gospel does not come from men, and that justification is not by works of the law. Now he turns to argue from Scripture and experience. He appeals first to the Galatians' own experience of receiving the Spirit, then to Abraham, then to the purpose of the law. He answers a question the false teachers raised: if the law doesn't justify, why was it given?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O foolish Galatians! Who has bewitched you?" (3:1).
2. "Now it is evident that no one is justified before God by the law, for The righteous shall live by faith" (3:11).
3. "Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us" (3:13).
4. "So then, the law was our guardian until Christ came, in order that we might be justified by faith" (3:24).
5. "There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither slave nor free, there is no male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus" (3:28).
6. "And if you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's offspring, heirs according to promise" (3:29).

7. “My little children, for whom I am again in the anguish of childbirth until Christ is formed in you” (4:19).

8. “Now you, brothers, like Isaac, are children of promise” (4:28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with a rebuke and a question: “O foolish Galatians! Who has bewitched you? It was before your eyes that Jesus Christ was publicly portrayed as crucified.” Then he asks: “Did you receive the Spirit by works of the law or by hearing with faith?” They received the Spirit when they first believed, by faith, not by works. Why think they will be perfected by the flesh?

Next Abraham: “Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness.” So the sons of Abraham are those of faith. Scripture foresaw that God would justify the Gentiles by faith and preached the gospel beforehand to Abraham: “In you shall all the nations be blessed.” Those who rely on works of the law are under a curse, for it is written, “Cursed be everyone who does not abide by all things written in the Book of the Law, and do them.” No one does. But “Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us.” The cross is where the curse fell. This was so that the blessing of Abraham might come to the Gentiles, and we might receive the promised Spirit through faith.

The law came 430 years after the promise and cannot annul it. If the inheritance comes by law, it no longer comes by promise, but God gave it to Abraham by promise. “Why then the law?” It was added because of transgressions, until the offspring should come. It was a temporary measure. It does not contradict the promises, but it could not give life. “So then, the law was our guardian until Christ came, in order that we might be justified by faith. But now that faith has come, we are no longer under a guardian.” The guardian (Greek paidagogos) was a slave who supervised a child, not a teacher. His job ended when the child grew up. This is a key text for understanding the relationship between the covenants: the Mosaic covenant had a temporary role in God’s plan, and Christ has brought its fulfillment. Christians differ over how much of the law continues to apply as moral guidance; all agree that it is not a means of justification, and that Christ fulfills it.

Then comes one of the greatest statements about the church: “For in Christ Jesus you are all sons of God, through faith. For as many of you as were baptized into Christ have put on Christ. There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither slave nor free, there is no male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus. And if you are Christ’s, then you are Abraham’s offspring, heirs according to promise.” All the divisions that separated people are overcome. Every believer has the same standing and the same inheritance. This does not erase all distinctions, but it removes them as grounds for status before God.

Chapter 4 continues with adoption (see yesterday's pause) and Paul's pastoral heart: "My little children, for whom I am again in the anguish of childbirth until Christ is formed in you." Then the allegory of Hagar and Sarah. Hagar represents the covenant from Mount Sinai, bearing children for slavery, corresponding to the present Jerusalem. Sarah represents the free woman, the Jerusalem above. "Now you, brothers, like Isaac, are children of promise." The one born according to the flesh persecuted the one born by the Spirit, and so it is now. But "what does the Scripture say? Cast out the slave woman and her son." We are not children of the slave but of the free woman.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 12:1-3, 15:1-6, and 17 are the Abrahamic covenant. Exodus 19 to 20 is Sinai. Deuteronomy 27:26 and 21:23 are cited in 3:10 and 3:13. Habakkuk 2:4 is cited in 3:11. Genesis 16 and 21 tell of Hagar and Sarah. Isaiah 54:1 is cited in 4:27. Jeremiah 31:31-34 promises the new covenant. Romans 4 gives a parallel argument. Hebrews 8 to 10 explain the old and new covenants. Colossians 2:16-17 says the old is a shadow and the substance belongs to Christ. Revelation 21:2 speaks of the new Jerusalem.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you are trying to be perfected by the flesh after beginning in the Spirit.

Thank Christ for becoming a curse for you. Say it slowly.

Seek out someone different from you, in age, background, or status, and show them the unity we have in Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Christ for becoming a curse for you.
- Thank him that you are a son or daughter and not a slave.
- Ask him to teach you to live in that freedom.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 108

“But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons.”

GALATIANS 4:4-5

DAY 756 · WEEK 108

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Galatians 4:4-5 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons."

GALATIANS 4:4-5

REST

Meditation

Four phrases carry the verse.

"When the fullness of time had come." History is not random. God had been preparing for centuries, through Abraham, Moses, David, and the prophets, until the moment he chose. The coming of Christ was right on schedule.

"God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law." The Son existed before he was sent. He was born of a woman, fully human, and born under the law, placing himself under the obligations of God's covenant with Israel. He lived the life we should have lived.

"To redeem those who were under the law." Redemption means buying back, the price paid to free a slave. He kept the law that we broke and bore the curse that we deserved.

“So that we might receive adoption as sons.” The goal is not just freedom, but family. We are not simply released; we are welcomed home.

Whenever you feel like a stranger or an orphan, say this verse. You were bought at a price in order to be brought home.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the unit on law, gospel, and the church by reading Galatians, Paul’s urgent defense of the gospel. In Galatians 1 and 2 you saw that there is no other gospel, that Paul’s message came by revelation, and that he opposed Peter at Antioch because the gospel is at stake in how we live together. In a doctrinal pause on adoption, you saw how the Father sent the Son and the Spirit so that sinners could become sons and daughters and cry “Abba! Father!” In Galatians 3 and 4, you read the case from Scripture: Abraham was justified by faith, Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law, the law was a temporary guardian, and in Christ all are sons and heirs. You also saw Paul’s allegory of Hagar and Sarah, with the contrast between slavery and freedom.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says the gospel cannot be added to. Is there anything you tend to add to faith in Christ as a requirement for being accepted by God, such as performance, a feeling, or a ritual? How does the cross answer that?

Galatians 3:13 says Christ became a curse for us. How does it affect you to know that Jesus took the curse that belonged to you? What does this make you want to say to him?

Which is harder for you to believe: that you are forgiven, or that you are a beloved son or daughter of the Father? What might help you rest in your adoption this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for sending his Son to redeem and adopt you.

Rest as his child.

Ask him to quiet any fear of not belonging.

DAY 757 · WEEK 109

Galatians 5:1-6:18

Christian freedom; the fruit of the Spirit; the new creation

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Galatians 5:1-6:18. Paul moves from the doctrine of freedom to its practice. Notice the contrast between flesh and Spirit, the fruit of the Spirit, and the closing summary about the cross and new creation.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has argued that we are justified by faith, not law. But does this freedom lead to a life of license? The opposite error was also a danger. In chapters 5 and 6, Paul shows how freedom works: we are called to freedom, but we use it to serve others in love, and we live by the Spirit who produces holiness. This is one of the best summaries of the Christian life in the New Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For freedom Christ has set us free; stand firm therefore, and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery" (5:1).
2. "For you were called to freedom, brothers. Only do not use your freedom as an opportunity for the flesh, but through love serve one another" (5:13).
3. "But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh" (5:16).
4. "But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control; against such things there is no law" (5:22-23).
5. "Bear one another's burdens, and so fulfill the law of Christ" (6:2).
6. "And let us not grow weary of doing good, for in due season we will reap, if we do not give up" (6:9).

7. “Far be it from me to boast except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ, by which the world has been crucified to me, and I to the world” (6:14).

8. “For neither circumcision counts for anything, nor uncircumcision, but a new creation” (6:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“For freedom Christ has set us free; stand firm therefore, and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery.” Paul warns that if the Galatians accept circumcision as a means of righteousness, Christ will be of no advantage to them, and they are obligated to keep the whole law. “You are severed from Christ, you who would be justified by the law; you have fallen away from grace.” In Christ Jesus, what counts is “faith working through love.”

Then the other danger: “You were called to freedom, brothers. Only do not use your freedom as an opportunity for the flesh, but through love serve one another. For the whole law is fulfilled in one word: You shall love your neighbor as yourself.” Freedom from the law is not freedom from love. It is freedom to love. “But if you bite and devour one another, watch out that you are not consumed by one another.”

The solution is the Spirit. “Walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh. For the desires of the flesh are against the Spirit, and the desires of the Spirit are against the flesh, for these are opposed to each other, to keep you from doing the things you want to do.” This is the war within every believer. The “works of the flesh” are obvious: sexual immorality, impurity, sensuality, idolatry, sorcery, enmity, strife, jealousy, fits of anger, rivalries, dissensions, divisions, envy, drunkenness, orgies. Those who do such things will not inherit the kingdom of God. Notice how many involve relationships.

In contrast, “the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control.” The singular “fruit” suggests one character with nine facets. It is the character of Christ. It grows; it is not manufactured. We cannot produce fruit by effort alone, but by abiding. And “those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires. If we live by the Spirit, let us also keep in step with the Spirit.”

Chapter 6 gives practical instructions: restore gently someone caught in a transgression, watching yourself lest you too be tempted. “Bear one another’s burdens, and so fulfill the law of Christ.” Each must also bear his own load (the daily responsibility). Share good things with those who teach. “Do not be deceived: God is not mocked, for whatever one sows, that will he also reap.” Sowing to the Spirit leads to eternal life. “Let us not grow weary of doing good.”

Paul takes the pen in his own hand to write the closing in large letters. His boast is not in circumcision or any achievement. “Far be it from me to boast except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ, by which the world has been crucified to me, and I to the world. For neither circumcision counts for anything, nor uncircumcision, but a new creation.” The cross is the center, and the new creation is the goal. “Peace and mercy be upon all who walk by this rule, upon the Israel of God.” Interpreters differ about whether “the Israel of God” means the church, composed of Jews and Gentiles, or believing Jews within the church. In a progressive covenantal reading, it points to the one people of God, united in Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 6 to 8 expands the same themes of freedom and the Spirit. Leviticus 19:18 is quoted in 5:14. John 15:1-17 shows fruit through abiding. Ephesians 4:1-6:20 and Colossians 3:1-17 give related moral teaching. Matthew 7:15-20 says a tree is known by its fruit. 2 Corinthians 5:17 speaks of new creation. Isaiah 65:17 and Revelation 21:5 promise all things new. Hebrews 12:1 calls us to lay aside weights. 1 Corinthians 2:2 shows Paul’s focus on the cross.

STEP 6

Application

Choose one fruit of the Spirit that you most need this week. Ask for it, and look for a place to practice it.

Ask whom you can help carry a burden. Do it quietly.

Put your name in 6:14. What do you boast in besides the cross?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for setting you free, and ask him to keep you from returning to slavery.
- Ask the Spirit to produce his fruit in you.
- Tell him which fruit you most need.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 109

“For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.”

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

DAY 758 · WEEK 109

1 Corinthians 1:1-2:16

The foolishness of the cross; wisdom from above

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 1:1-2:16. Paul begins his letter to a gifted but divided church. Notice how he answers pride and division with the cross. Pay particular attention to 1:18-31 and 2:1-5.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Corinth was a wealthy, cosmopolitan port city in Greece, known for commerce, sensuality, and a love of rhetoric. Paul planted the church around AD 50 during an eighteen-month stay (Acts 18). By AD 55 he writes from Ephesus in response to reports and a letter from the church. They had problems: factions around favorite leaders, moral scandal, lawsuits, confusion about marriage, abuse of the Lord's Supper, disorder in worship, and doubts about the resurrection. First Corinthians is a letter for a messy church, and so it is very relevant. Paul's answer to every problem is Christ and him crucified.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God" (1:18).
2. "We preach Christ crucified, a stumbling block to Jews and folly to Gentiles" (1:23).
3. "For the foolishness of God is wiser than men, and the weakness of God is stronger than men" (1:25).
4. "He is the source of your life in Christ Jesus, who became to us wisdom from God, righteousness and sanctification and redemption" (1:30).
5. "Let the one who boasts, boast in the Lord" (1:31).

6. “For I decided to know nothing among you except Jesus Christ and him crucified” (2:2).
7. “These things God has revealed to us through the Spirit” (2:10).
8. “But we have the mind of Christ” (2:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul greets the church as “sanctified in Christ Jesus, called to be saints.” Despite their failings, they belong to God. He thanks God for the grace given them: they are enriched in speech and knowledge, lacking in no gift, waiting for the revealing of Christ. Then he turns to the first problem: quarrels. “I appeal to you, brothers… that all of you agree, and that there be no divisions among you.” Some said, “I follow Paul,” others, “I follow Apollos,” others Cephas, others Christ. “Is Christ divided? Was Paul crucified for you?”

His answer is the cross. “The word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.” The world seeks signs and wisdom, but “we preach Christ crucified, a stumbling block to Jews and folly to Gentiles, but to those who are called, both Jews and Greeks, Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God.” The message that seems weak and foolish is God’s chosen method. “The foolishness of God is wiser than men, and the weakness of God is stronger than men.”

Look at who you are, he says. Not many were wise, powerful, or of noble birth. “God chose what is foolish in the world to shame the wise; God chose what is weak in the world to shame the strong.” So that no one might boast in the presence of God. “He is the source of your life in Christ Jesus, who became to us wisdom from God, righteousness and sanctification and redemption.” Christ is everything. “Let the one who boasts, boast in the Lord.”

In chapter 2, Paul describes his own ministry. He did not come with lofty speech or wisdom. “I decided to know nothing among you except Jesus Christ and him crucified.” He came in weakness and much trembling, and his message was not in plausible words of wisdom but in demonstration of the Spirit and of power, “that your faith might not rest in the wisdom of men but in the power of God.”

Yet there is a wisdom to be spoken among the mature: not the wisdom of this age, but God’s secret and hidden wisdom, decreed before the ages for our glory. None of the rulers of this age understood it, for if they had, they would not have crucified the Lord of glory. It is revealed through the Spirit, who searches everything, even the depths of God. “No one comprehends the thoughts of God except the Spirit of God.” We have received the Spirit, so that we might understand the gifts freely given to us.

“The natural person does not accept the things of the Spirit of God, for they are folly to him, and he is not able to understand them because they are spiritually discerned.” This explains why people without the Spirit find the gospel foolish. And the chapter ends with a wonderful statement: “But we have the mind of Christ.” By the Spirit, believers can think God’s thoughts after him through his word.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 29:14 and Jeremiah 9:23-24 are quoted in chapter 1. Acts 18:1-18 tells of the founding of the church. Isaiah 64:4 and 40:13 are quoted in chapter 2. Galatians 6:14 is a parallel boast in the cross. Philippians 2:1-11 speaks of the mind of Christ. John 16:13-15 promises the Spirit who guides into truth. Romans 1:16 and Colossians 2:2-3 speak of Christ as the center. 1 Peter 2:4-8 says Christ is a stone of stumbling. Ephesians 1:17-18 prays for the Spirit of wisdom.

STEP 6

Application

Ask if you are boasting in a leader, a ministry, or a tradition more than in Christ. Replace the boast.

Pray for the Spirit to illumine a passage as you read Scripture this week.

If you feel weak or foolish in the world’s eyes, remember that God chose the weak.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the foolishness of the cross that saves you.
- Ask him to keep your eyes on Christ crucified.
- Tell him where you are tempted to rely on human wisdom.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 109

“For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.”

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

DAY 759 · WEEK 109

1 Corinthians 3:1-4:21

The church as God's field; apostolic ministry

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 3:1-4:21. Paul continues to deal with divisions by showing how God sees ministers and the church. Notice the pictures: a field, a building, a temple. Notice also what Paul says about being a steward.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has said that the cross confounds human wisdom. Now he applies this to the church's attitude to its leaders. The Corinthians were comparing teachers like sports fans choosing favorite athletes. Paul wants them to see that ministers are servants and that the church is God's own possession.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I planted, Apollos watered, but God gave the growth" (3:6).
2. "For no one can lay a foundation other than that which is laid, which is Jesus Christ" (3:11).
3. "Do you not know that you are God's temple and that God's Spirit dwells in you?" (3:16).
4. "And you are Christ's, and Christ is God's" (3:23).
5. "This is how one should regard us, as servants of Christ and stewards of the mysteries of God" (4:1).
6. "Moreover, it is required of stewards that they be found faithful" (4:2).
7. "What do you have that you did not receive?" (4:7).
8. "For the kingdom of God does not consist in talk but in power" (4:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul says he could not address them as spiritual people but as people of the flesh, infants in Christ. They were still being fed milk. Their jealousy and strife showed it. “For when one says, I follow Paul, and another, I follow Apollos, are you not being merely human?” Then he gives the right view of ministry: “What then is Apollos? What is Paul? Servants through whom you believed, as the Lord assigned to each. I planted, Apollos watered, but God gave the growth. So neither he who plants nor he who waters is anything, but only God who gives the growth.” Ministers are workers; God is the source of life.

The church is “God’s field, God’s building.” Paul laid a foundation as a wise master builder, and others build on it. “No one can lay a foundation other than that which is laid, which is Jesus Christ.” Each builder must take care how he builds. The quality of each person’s work will be revealed on the day of judgment, tested by fire. Gold, silver, and precious stones endure; wood, hay, and straw burn. If the work survives, the builder receives a reward; if it is burned up, he suffers loss, though he himself will be saved, as through fire. This passage encourages teachers and builders to serve with care, building with the truth.

Then: “Do you not know that you are God’s temple and that God’s Spirit dwells in you? If anyone destroys God’s temple, God will destroy him. For God’s temple is holy, and you are that temple.” Notice that “you” is plural. The church is the dwelling of God’s Spirit. Dividing the church is a serious sin because it damages God’s temple.

Paul urges them to be wise by becoming fools in the world’s eyes, “for the wisdom of this world is folly with God.” And do not boast in men. “For all things are yours, whether Paul or Apollos or Cephas or the world or life or death or the present or the future, all are yours, and you are Christ’s, and Christ is God’s.” The church does not belong to its leaders; the leaders belong to the church, and the church belongs to Christ.

In chapter 4, Paul describes true ministers as “servants of Christ and stewards of the mysteries of God.” A steward manages what belongs to another, and he must be faithful. Paul does not worry about human judgment, or even his own self-assessment: “It is the Lord who judges me.” He gives a sharp contrast between the proud Corinthians, who think themselves kings, and the apostles, who are “a spectacle to the world,” “fools for Christ’s sake,” hungry and homeless, reviled and slandered. “What do you have that you did not receive? If then you received it, why do you boast as if you had not received it?” He closes as a father: “I became your father in Christ Jesus through the gospel.” And he warns that he will come, if the Lord wills, to see not the talk but the power.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 28:16 speaks of the cornerstone. Ephesians 2:19-22 says the church is a holy temple in the Lord. 1 Peter 2:4-10 describes living stones. Matthew 7:24-27 shows building on the rock. 2 Corinthians 6:16 repeats that we are the temple of the living God. 1 Timothy 3:15 calls the church the pillar and buttress of the truth. Luke 12:42-48 describes the faithful steward. Romans 11:36 speaks of all things from him. 1 Peter 5:1-4 is a charge to elders.

STEP 6

Application

Thank a person who planted or watered in your life. Remember that God gave the growth.

Ask what you are building with: gold, silver, or straw. How could your ministry or your work last?

Look at your gifts and abilities and ask, What do I have that I did not receive?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he alone gives growth.

Thank him for those who planted and watered in your life.

Ask him to make Christ your only foundation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 109

"For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God."

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

DAY 760 · WEEK 109

Psalm 33

God's word stands; rest in God alone

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 33. It is a song of praise that begins in joy and ends in waiting. Notice how the psalm moves from God's creating word to his counsel to the waiting soul, and how it connects to Paul's argument that God's wisdom is greater than the world's.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 33 has no title, but it follows Psalm 32 as a joyful response to forgiveness. It is a hymn of praise that celebrates God's word, his creation, and his rule over the nations. In Corinthians, Paul has just been arguing that God's ways overturn the wisdom of the world and its strength. This psalm sings the same truth: kings and armies cannot save, but the LORD can.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For the word of the LORD is upright, and all his work is done in faithfulness" (v. 4).
2. "By the word of the LORD the heavens were made, and by the breath of his mouth all their host" (v. 6).
3. "For he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm" (v. 9).
4. "The counsel of the LORD stands forever, the plans of his heart to all generations" (v. 11).
5. "Blessed is the nation whose God is the LORD, the people whom he has chosen as his heritage!" (v. 12).
6. "Behold, the eye of the LORD is on those who fear him, on those who hope in his steadfast love" (v. 18).

7. “Our soul waits for the LORD; he is our help and our shield” (v. 20).

8. “Let your steadfast love, O LORD, be upon us, even as we hope in you” (v. 22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a summons: “Shout for joy in the LORD, O you righteous! Praise befits the upright.” It calls for a new song with skill and loud shouts, and with the harp and the lyre. The reason for praise is the word of the LORD. His word is upright, and all his work is done in faithfulness. He loves righteousness and justice, and the earth is full of his steadfast love.

Then the psalm turns to creation. “By the word of the LORD the heavens were made, and by the breath of his mouth all their host.” This echoes Genesis 1, where God speaks and things come to be. “For he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm.” The word of God is powerful and effective. In the New Testament, the Word through whom all things were made is Christ (John 1:1-3). And the “breath of his mouth” can also be heard as the Spirit. The whole Trinity is at work in creation.

The word of the LORD is also the plan of history. “The LORD brings the counsel of the nations to nothing; he frustrates the plans of the peoples. The counsel of the LORD stands forever, the plans of his heart to all generations.” Human schemes rise and fall, but God’s purpose stands. This is the same idea as in 1 Corinthians 1: the wisdom of the world will be undone, but God’s wisdom remains. Notice the blessing for the people he has chosen as his heritage: “Blessed is the nation whose God is the LORD.”

God sees everything. From heaven he looks down on all the children of man; he fashions the hearts of all and observes all their deeds. The conclusion: “The king is not saved by his great army; a warrior is not delivered by his great strength. The war horse is a false hope for salvation, and by its great might it cannot rescue.” Military power, wealth, and human strength cannot save. The true safety is in the LORD.

“Behold, the eye of the LORD is on those who fear him, on those who hope in his steadfast love, that he may deliver their soul from death and keep them alive in famine.” The psalm ends in humility and trust. “Our soul waits for the LORD; he is our help and our shield. For our heart is glad in him, because we trust in his holy name.” And the final prayer: “Let your steadfast love, O LORD, be upon us, even as we hope in you.” Waiting is the posture of faith.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1 shows creation by God's word. John 1:1-3 and Colossians 1:16 say all things were made through Christ. Hebrews 11:3 says the universe was created by the word of God. Psalm 20:7 and 147:10-11 also contrast chariots and horses with God. Isaiah 40:8 says the word of our God will stand forever. Isaiah 46:10 says my counsel shall stand. Proverbs 19:21 contrasts human plans with the LORD's purpose. 1 Corinthians 1:18-31 is the parallel argument.

STEP 6

Application

Sing or read this psalm aloud. Give thanks for something the LORD has made.

Name a plan or worry that depends on human strength. Entrust it to God.

Practice waiting on the LORD without rushing to fix things. Say verse 20 as a prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his word is upright and his counsel stands forever.

Tell him what plans of yours you want to place under his.

Ask him to let his steadfast love be upon you as you hope in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 109

"For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God."

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

DAY 761 · WEEK 109

Psalm 62

For God alone my soul waits in silence

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 62. It is a psalm of quiet trust by David. Notice the repeated word “alone” and how it deals with the temptation to trust in people, power, or wealth.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 62 is a psalm of David, probably from a time when enemies were plotting against him. It is a calm psalm in the middle of threat. The key word is “alone”: God alone is my rock. In Corinth, believers were tempted to trust in human leaders and human wisdom. This psalm calls us back to rest in God alone.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “For God alone my soul waits in silence; from him comes my salvation” (v. 1).
2. “He alone is my rock and my salvation, my fortress; I shall not be greatly shaken” (v. 2).
3. “For God alone, O my soul, wait in silence, for my hope is from him” (v. 5).
4. “On God rests my salvation and my glory; my mighty rock, my refuge is God” (v. 7).
5. “Trust in him at all times, O people; pour out your heart before him; God is a refuge for us” (v. 8).
6. “Those of low estate are but a breath; those of high estate are a delusion” (v. 9).
7. “If riches increase, set not your heart on them” (v. 10).
8. “Once God has spoken; twice have I heard this: that power belongs to God” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David opens, “For God alone my soul waits in silence; from him comes my salvation.” The Hebrew has a sense of silence and stillness: the soul is quiet before God. He is not silent because he has no words, but because he is resting. “He alone is my rock and my salvation, my fortress; I shall not be greatly shaken.” The word “alone” appears six times in the psalm. It narrows trust to one object.

Then he addresses his enemies: “How long will all of you attack a man to batter him, like a leaning wall, a tottering fence?” They plan to thrust him down from his high position. They take pleasure in falsehood; they bless with their mouths, but inwardly they curse. In the face of this, David speaks to his own soul: “For God alone, O my soul, wait in silence, for my hope is from him.” He repeats verses 1 and 2 almost word for word, with a slight change. In the first, “I shall not be greatly shaken.” In the second, “I shall not be shaken.” His confidence grows as he preaches to himself.

Verse 8 turns outward to the people: “Trust in him at all times, O people; pour out your heart before him; God is a refuge for us.” Prayer is pouring out the heart. Then David exposes the false refuges: “Those of low estate are but a breath; those of high estate are a delusion; in the balances they go up; they are together lighter than a breath.” People of any rank, high or low, cannot hold up your weight. Neither can wealth: “Put no trust in extortion; set no vain hopes on robbery. If riches increase, set not your heart on them.” Money is not evil, but it is a poor god.

The psalm ends with God’s word: “Once God has spoken; twice have I heard this: that power belongs to God, and that to you, O Lord, belongs steadfast love. For you will render to a man according to his work.” God is both strong and kind. Power without love would be terrifying; love without power would be useless. God has both.

The cross shows both. The power of God is displayed in weakness; the love of God is shown in sacrifice. This is the paradox that Paul preached in Corinth. Rest in God alone, and pour out your heart to him.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 37:7 says be still before the LORD and wait patiently for him. Psalm 46:10 says be still and know that I am God. Isaiah 30:15 says in returning and rest you shall be saved. Lamentations 3:25-26 says it is good to wait quietly. Matthew 6:19-24 warns about treasures and serving two masters. 1 Timothy 6:17-19 addresses the rich. Jeremiah 17:5-8 contrasts trust in man with trust in the LORD. Romans 2:6 echoes verse 12. Philippians 4:6-7 speaks of prayer and peace.

STEP 6

Application

Sit in silence for five minutes today. Practice waiting on God alone.

Ask where you are trusting in people, position, or money. Name one and entrust it to God.

Pour out your heart to God in prayer today, without editing.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Wait on God in silence for a moment, and then tell him what you hope for.
- Thank him that he is your rock and fortress.
- Pour out your heart to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 109

"For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God."

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

DAY 762 · WEEK 109

1 Corinthians 5:1-7:40

Church discipline; lawsuits; marriage and sexuality

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 101 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 5:1-7:40. This is a long reading on hard topics: sexual sin in the church, lawsuits, sexuality, and marriage. Read it carefully and with humility. Notice that Paul grounds his commands in the gospel: you were washed, you were bought with a price.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul now deals with specific problems reported to him. Chapter 5 concerns a man living in sexual immorality of a kind that even pagans would not tolerate, and the church's proud tolerance of it. Chapter 6 addresses believers suing each other in pagan courts, and sexual sin. Chapter 7 begins his response to the church's letter, "Now concerning the matters about which you wrote," with a long discussion of marriage, singleness, and divorce. Corinth had a reputation for sexual license, and some believers swung to the opposite extreme of asceticism.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed" (5:7).
2. "For what have I to do with judging outsiders? Is it not those inside the church whom you are to judge?" (5:12).
3. "And such were some of you. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God" (6:11).
4. "Flee from sexual immorality" (6:18).
5. "You are not your own, for you were bought with a price. So glorify God in your body" (6:19-20).

6. “Each has his own gift from God, one of one kind and one of another” (7:7).
7. “Only let each person lead the life that the Lord has assigned to him, and to which God has called him” (7:17).
8. “You were bought with a price; do not become slaves of men” (7:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

A man is living with his father’s wife, and the church is arrogant instead of grieving. Paul tells them to remove him from their fellowship, “to deliver this man to Satan for the destruction of the flesh, so that his spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord.” Church discipline has a redemptive goal. He uses the picture of leaven: “a little leaven leavens the whole lump.” And the gospel is the basis: “Cleanse out the old leaven that you may be a new lump, as you really are unleavened. For Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed.” The church is to be what it already is in Christ. Paul distinguishes judgment of those inside the church from those outside; God judges outsiders.

In chapter 6, Paul rebukes believers who take each other to court before unbelievers. “Do you not know that the saints will judge the world?” Surely they can settle ordinary matters. It is better to be wronged. Then he lists the unrighteous who will not inherit the kingdom of God: the sexually immoral, idolaters, adulterers, men who practice homosexuality, thieves, the greedy, drunkards, revilers, swindlers. “And such were some of you. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God.” The words “such were some of you” are among the most hopeful in the Bible. No one is beyond the reach of the gospel, and no one is allowed to stay as they were.

Paul rejects the slogan “All things are lawful for me.” Not all things are helpful. The body is not for sexual immorality but for the Lord, and the Lord for the body. God raised the Lord and will raise us. Our bodies are members of Christ. “Flee from sexual immorality. Every other sin a person commits is outside the body, but the sexually immoral person sins against his own body.” Then: “Or do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit within you, whom you have from God? You are not your own, for you were bought with a price. So glorify God in your body.” This is the basis for Christian ethics: we belong to Christ, body and soul.

In chapter 7, Paul addresses marriage and singleness. Marriage is good, and sexual relations within marriage are a duty and a gift, to be mutual. He speaks of his own singleness as a gift: “Each has his own gift from God, one of one kind and one of another.” To the married he gives the Lord’s command that a wife should not separate from her husband, nor a husband divorce his wife. If a believer has an unbelieving spouse who is willing to stay, they should stay. “But if the unbelieving partner separates, let it be so. In such cases the brother or sister

is not enslaved." Christians differ on what this means for divorce and remarriage: some hold that 7:15 allows remarriage after desertion, and others hold stricter or looser positions. Pastoral care and prayer are essential.

The chapter has a repeated principle: "Let each person lead the life that the Lord has assigned to him." Whether married, single, circumcised, or slave, we serve the Lord where he has placed us. Paul urges single believers to consider the advantage of undivided devotion, but this is a counsel, not a command. And "the appointed time has grown very short." The form of this world is passing away. Hold earthly relationships with an eye on eternity.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 18:8 and Deuteronomy 22:30 forbid the sin in chapter 5. Exodus 12 describes the Passover. Matthew 18:15-20 gives the process of discipline. 2 Corinthians 2:5-11 may describe the repentance of this man. Genesis 2:24 is quoted in 6:16. Ephesians 5:22-33 speaks of marriage as Christ and the church. Matthew 19:1-12 is Jesus' teaching on divorce and singleness. Hebrews 13:4 honors marriage. Romans 6:1-14 and 1 Thessalonians 4:1-8 teach holiness. Daniel 7:22 says the saints will judge.

STEP 6

Application

Say 6:11 aloud and put your name in it. You were washed, sanctified, and justified.

Ask where you belong to yourself instead of Christ. Offer your body to him.

If you are single or married, ask God to show you how to serve him fully where you are. Pray for someone in a hard marriage.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being your Passover lamb.
- Thank him that you were washed, sanctified, and justified.
- Ask him to help you flee what harms you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 109

“For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.”

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

DAY 763 · WEEK 109

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Corinthians 1:18 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God."

1 CORINTHIANS 1:18

REST

Meditation

Paul writes this verse to a church that was dazzled by wisdom and rhetoric.

"The word of the cross." The gospel is a message about a crucifixion. In the ancient world, crucifixion was the most shameful death, reserved for slaves and rebels. To say that God's salvation came through a crucified man sounded insane.

"Is folly to those who are perishing." To those who are on the way to destruction, the message looks like nonsense. This is not because the message is irrational, but because sin has darkened understanding. Without the Spirit, no one sees its glory.

"But to us who are being saved." The present tense describes an ongoing process: we are being saved, as the Spirit applies the gospel to our lives. The verse divides humanity into two groups, and the dividing line is the cross.

“It is the power of God.” What looks like weakness is strength. The cross is not just the means of forgiveness but the power that changes lives, raises the dead, and breaks the grip of sin.

If you are ever embarrassed by the gospel, say this verse. The message you carry is the power of God.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished Galatians and began 1 Corinthians. Galatians 5 and 6 showed how freedom in Christ works: through love, by walking in the Spirit, producing the fruit of the Spirit, bearing one another’s burdens, and boasting in nothing but the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ. First Corinthians opened with a divided, gifted church, and Paul answered every division with the word of the cross, the power and wisdom of God. You studied the church as God’s field, building, and temple, with ministers as servants and stewards. Two psalms taught trust: Psalm 33, the counsel of the LORD stands forever, and Psalm 62, for God alone my soul waits in silence. In chapters 5 to 7, Paul dealt with sexual sin, lawsuits, and marriage, always grounding his commands in the gospel: you were washed, sanctified, and justified, and you were bought with a price.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says the message of the cross seems foolish to the world. Where do you feel pressure to make the gospel more impressive or more respectable? What would it look like to trust the cross itself?

First Corinthians 6:11 says “such were some of you” but you were washed, sanctified, and justified. How does this verse change the way you see your past, and the way you see those who are far from God?

Psalm 62 says “For God alone my soul waits in silence.” What is one thing you tend to rely on besides God alone? What would it look like to wait on him this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that the word of the cross is the power of God.

Thank him that you are being saved.

Rest in what he has done.

DAY 764 · WEEK 110

1 Corinthians 8:1-10:33

Christian freedom; idolatry; love limits liberty

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 95 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 8:1-10:33. These three chapters answer a question about food offered to idols. Read for the principle: how do Christians use their freedom? Notice Paul's own example in chapter 9, the warning from Israel in chapter 10, and the closing command in 10:31.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Much of the meat sold in Corinth had first been offered to idols in pagan temples. Some believers said that since idols are nothing, eating that meat was fine. Others, who had been idol worshipers, felt that eating it was a return to idolatry. Paul does not simply side with the strong. He offers principles of knowledge, love, freedom, and warning that apply well beyond food. Typical situations today include entertainment, drinking, holidays, and cultural practices.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "This knowledge puffs up, but love builds up" (8:1).
2. "Yet for us there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things and for whom we exist, and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things and through whom we exist" (8:6).
3. "For though I am free from all, I have made myself a servant to all, that I might win more of them" (9:19).
4. "I have become all things to all people, that by all means I might save some" (9:22).
5. "And all drank the same spiritual drink. For they were drinking from the spiritual Rock that followed them, and the Rock was Christ" (10:4).

6. “Now these things happened to them as an example, but they were written down for our instruction, on whom the end of the ages has come” (10:11).
7. “God is faithful, and he will not let you be tempted beyond your ability” (10:13).
8. “So, whether you eat or drink, or whatever you do, do all to the glory of God” (10:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul starts with a general principle: “Knowledge puffs up, but love builds up.” It is possible to be right and unloving. He agrees with the strong in doctrine: “An idol has no real existence, and there is no God but one.” The great confession of 8:6 echoes the Shema: “For us there is one God, the Father… and one Lord, Jesus Christ.” Paul places Jesus within the identity of the one God. Yet not everyone has this knowledge, and a weaker conscience may be defiled. “Take care that this right of yours does not somehow become a stumbling block to the weak.” Love limits liberty: “If food is a cause of my brother’s stumbling, I will never eat meat, lest I cause my brother to stumble.”

In chapter 9, Paul uses himself as an example. He is an apostle with rights: to eat and drink, to be married, to be supported by the churches, as the Lord commanded that those who proclaim the gospel get their living by the gospel. “But I have made no use of any of these rights.” He renounces them to avoid putting an obstacle in the way of the gospel. “For though I am free from all, I have made myself a servant to all, that I might win more of them.” To the Jews he became as a Jew; to those under the law as under the law; to those outside the law as outside the law, though not outside the law of God; to the weak, weak. “I have become all things to all people, that by all means I might save some. I do it all for the sake of the gospel.” Paul adapts his behavior, not his message. Then he compares the Christian life to a race and to boxing, with self-discipline and an imperishable crown.

Chapter 10 warns from Israel’s history. All were baptized into Moses in the cloud and the sea, all ate the same spiritual food and drank the same spiritual drink, “for they were drinking from the spiritual Rock that followed them, and the Rock was Christ.” Yet with most of them God was not pleased, and they were overthrown in the wilderness. Idolatry, immorality, testing the Lord, and grumbling brought judgment. “These things happened to them as an example, but they were written down for our instruction, on whom the end of the ages has come. Therefore let anyone who thinks that he stands take heed lest he fall.” This is a key text for reading the Old Testament as Christian Scripture: Christ was present in Israel’s story, and its lessons are for us.

And then comfort: “No temptation has overtaken you that is not common to man. God is faithful, and he will not let you be tempted beyond your ability, but with the temptation he will also provide the way of escape, that you may be able to endure it.” The instruction is to

flee idolatry. The Lord's Supper is a participation in the blood and body of Christ, and one cannot partake of the table of the Lord and the table of demons.

The closing principles in 10:23 to 11:1: not everything is helpful, seek the good of your neighbor, give thanks, and avoid causing offense. "So, whether you eat or drink, or whatever you do, do all to the glory of God." Give no offense to Jews, Greeks, or the church of God. "Be imitators of me, as I am of Christ."

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 6:4 is the Shema, which Paul reworks in 8:6. Numbers 11, 14, 16, 21, and 25 describe the wilderness failures. Exodus 14 and 17 describe the sea and the rock. Romans 14 to 15 treats a similar question. Acts 15:28-29 and Revelation 2:14, 20 address meat offered to idols. Philippians 3:12-14 and 2 Timothy 4:7 speak of the race. Hebrews 3 to 4 also draw lessons from Israel's wilderness. John 4:34 and Colossians 3:17 speak of doing all for God.

STEP 6

Application

Name a freedom you have that might hinder a friend or new believer. Be willing to give it up for love.

Ask yourself: Does my knowledge puff me up or build up others?

Do one ordinary thing today, eating or working, "to the glory of God" and say so in your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the one God and one Lord.

Ask him to keep your knowledge from puffing you up and make you loving.

Ask him to help you give up a liberty if it would help a brother or sister.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 110

“So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love.”

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

DAY 765 · WEEK 110

1 Corinthians 11:17-34; Luke 22:14-20; Matthew 26:26-29

The Sacraments, The Lord's Supper

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 11:17-34, Luke 22:14-20, and Matthew 26:26-29. Today is a doctrinal pause on the Lord's Supper. Notice what Jesus said and did, and how Paul corrects the Corinthians' abuse of the meal.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

On the night he was betrayed, Jesus celebrated the Passover with his disciples and gave them a new meal. From the beginning the church repeated this meal. By the time Paul wrote, it was a regular part of church gatherings. In Corinth, the meal had been corrupted: the rich ate and drank to excess while the poor went hungry, so the meal became a mark of division, not unity. Paul's correction tells us what the Supper is meant to be.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I have earnestly desired to eat this Passover with you before I suffer" (Luke 22:15).
2. "This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me" (Luke 22:19).
3. "This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood" (Luke 22:20).
4. "For this is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins" (Matthew 26:28).
5. "I tell you I will not drink again of this fruit of the vine until that day when I drink it new with you in my Father's kingdom" (Matthew 26:29).
6. "For as often as you eat this bread and drink the cup, you proclaim the Lord's death until he comes" (1 Corinthians 11:26).

7. “Let a person examine himself, then, and so eat of the bread and drink of the cup” (1 Corinthians 11:28).

8. “For anyone who eats and drinks without discerning the body eats and drinks judgment on himself” (1 Corinthians 11:29).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Lord’s Supper (also called Communion, the Eucharist, or the Lord’s Table) is the meal in which Christ’s people eat bread and drink the cup in remembrance of his death. Jesus instituted it at the Last Supper, and the church has observed it since the first century. It has several meanings. It looks back: “Do this in remembrance of me.” It proclaims: “You proclaim the Lord’s death.” It looks forward: “until he comes,” and Jesus pointed to the feast in the kingdom. It signifies and seals the new covenant in his blood, the forgiveness of sins. And it signifies our unity: “Because there is one bread, we who are many are one body, for we all partake of the one bread” (1 Corinthians 10:17).

Christians have disagreed about how Christ is present in the Supper, and this is one of the major differences between traditions. Roman Catholics hold that the bread and wine become the body and blood of Christ (transubstantiation). Lutherans hold that Christ’s body and blood are truly present “in, with, and under” the elements. Reformed Christians (following Calvin) hold that Christ is truly present by the Spirit, and the believer feeds on him by faith, though not physically in the elements. Many Baptists and others hold that the Supper is primarily a memorial and proclamation, an ordinance in which Christ is remembered. Traditions also differ on who may partake, how often, and who may administer. These matters deserve serious study and respect for one another.

What all agree on is that the Supper is a gift of grace for believers and a means of strengthening faith. It is to be approached with self-examination, not to earn forgiveness but to repent, trust, and be reconciled. It is to be shared in a way that honors the unity of the body. And it points beyond itself: the table is a foretaste of the wedding supper of the Lamb.

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Luke 22, Jesus says, “I have earnestly desired to eat this Passover with you before I suffer.” He knew what lay ahead and still longed for fellowship with his friends. The Passover meal remembered God’s rescue of Israel from Egypt, with the blood of a lamb protecting the firstborn. Jesus takes the bread, gives thanks, breaks it, and says, “This is my body, which is given for you.” After supper he takes the cup: “This cup that is poured out for you is the new

covenant in my blood." Matthew adds, "for the forgiveness of sins." He is the Lamb, and his blood establishes the new covenant that Jeremiah promised (31:31-34). And he looks ahead: he will not drink again until he drinks it new in the kingdom.

In 1 Corinthians 11, Paul first rebukes the divisions at the meal: "When you come together, it is not the Lord's supper that you eat. For in eating, each one goes ahead with his own meal. One goes hungry, another gets drunk." They were humiliating the poor. Then he recalls what he received from the Lord: Jesus on the night he was betrayed took bread, gave thanks, broke it, and said, "This is my body which is for you. Do this in remembrance of me." Likewise the cup. The Supper is a proclamation of the Lord's death.

Paul warns: "Whoever, therefore, eats the bread or drinks the cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty concerning the body and blood of the Lord." The "unworthy manner" refers to how they ate, with contempt for the poor, not that the person is unworthy, since no one is worthy in himself. "Let a person examine himself, then." We examine our hearts and our relationships. Some had become weak, ill, or had died, as a disciplinary judgment from the Lord, "that we may not be condemned along with the world." It is a sober reminder. The right response is not to avoid the table but to come repentant and in unity: "When you come together to eat, wait for one another."

Taking the Supper is one of the plainest ways the gospel is displayed. We do not make the meal; we receive it. We do not offer a sacrifice; we receive the benefits of the one sacrifice. And we eat together, which shows that we are one family.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 12 describes the Passover. Exodus 24:8 speaks of the blood of the covenant. Jeremiah 31:31-34 promises the new covenant. John 6:22-59 is Jesus' bread of life discourse. 1 Corinthians 10:14-22 speaks of participation. Isaiah 25:6-8 pictures the feast on the mountain. Revelation 19:6-9 describes the marriage supper of the Lamb. Acts 2:42 and 20:7 show the early church breaking bread. Hebrews 9:11-10:18 explains the once-for-all sacrifice. Matthew 5:23-24 speaks of reconciliation before worship.

STEP 6

Application

Before your next Communion, spend time examining your heart. Ask whether you are at peace with others.

Read the words of institution slowly and picture the upper room.

Pray for unity in your church and for those in your church who are poor or left out.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for the bread and the cup.

Ask him to teach you to come to his table with reverence and joy.

Ask him to remind you of his death until he comes.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 110

"So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love."

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

DAY 766 · WEEK 110

1 Corinthians 11:1-34

Head coverings; the Lord's Supper

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 34 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 11:1-34. The chapter has two parts: guidance on worship conduct (verses 2-16) and the Lord's Supper (verses 17-34). You read about the Supper yesterday. Today give attention to verses 2-16, which are some of the hardest in the letter to interpret, and read them with humility.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul begins a new section on public worship. He first praises them for remembering him and holding to the traditions as he delivered them. Then he addresses a problem in worship that involved how men and women dressed or wore their hair when praying or prophesying. The details of the first-century practice are not entirely clear to us, which is why interpreters have differed for centuries. What is clear is that both men and women prayed and prophesied in the gathered church, and that Paul cared about order and about honoring Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Be imitators of me, as I am of Christ" (11:1).
2. "Nevertheless, in the Lord woman is not independent of man nor man of woman" (11:11).
3. "If anyone is inclined to be contentious, we have no such practice, nor do the churches of God" (11:16).
4. "When you come together as a church, I hear that there are divisions among you" (11:18).
5. "Each one goes ahead with his own meal. One goes hungry, another gets drunk" (11:21).

6. “For I received from the Lord what I also delivered to you” (11:23).
7. “This cup is the new covenant in my blood. Do this, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of me” (11:25).
8. “When you come together to eat, wait for one another” (11:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter opens with a command that belongs to the previous section: “Be imitators of me, as I am of Christ.” Then Paul commends them for keeping the traditions. “But I want you to understand that the head of every man is Christ, the head of a wife is her husband, and the head of Christ is God.” The word translated “head” (kephale) is debated. Some understand it as authority, leading to a view that men have a leading role in the home and church. Others understand it as source or origin, since the passage speaks of woman coming from man in creation. Christians who love the Bible land in different places, so we should be gracious.

Paul then gives instructions about heads being covered or uncovered when praying or prophesying. It is likely that the issue was cultural markers of honor and shame in Corinth, and that Paul wanted men and women to present themselves in a way that did not bring disgrace or confusion about the gender distinctions God made. Some churches have taken this passage as requiring head coverings for women today; others see the principle as honoring order and distinction while the specific custom was cultural. Paul himself says, “We have no such practice, nor do the churches of God,” for those who are contentious. What is beyond dispute is verse 11: “In the Lord woman is not independent of man nor man of woman; for as woman was made from man, so man is now born of woman. And all things are from God.” Men and women need one another, and both are from God. And Paul assumes that women pray and prophesy in the assembly.

Verses 17 to 34 return to the Lord’s Supper, which you studied yesterday. Paul says the divisions among them are in a sense necessary “in order that those who are genuine among you may be recognized.” Their meal was becoming a display of status. “Do you despise the church of God and humiliate those who have nothing?” This is a rebuke of the rich who eat first. Paul then recalls the Lord’s own words. The Supper is a proclamation of the cross and a call to unity.

Self-examination and discerning the body (the church) are both required. The weak and sick among them show the seriousness of misusing the meal. Paul’s practical conclusion is simple: “So then, my brothers, when you come together to eat, wait for one another. If anyone is hungry, let him eat at home, so that when you come together it will not be for judgment.”

The big idea of the chapter is that worship is ordered by the gospel. Whatever our practice, it must honor Christ, build up the church, and care for the weak.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:26-27 and 2:18-23 are the creation background. Ephesians 5:21-33 speaks of headship and love. Galatians 3:28 says there is no male and female in Christ. Acts 2:17-18 and 21:9 mention women prophesying. 1 Timothy 2:8-15 also addresses worship. Luke 22:19-20 is the institution of the Supper. 1 Corinthians 10:16-17 speaks of participation. James 2:1-9 warns against partiality toward the rich. Hebrews 13:7 says to imitate the faith of leaders. Philippians 2:3-4 urges us to look to the interests of others.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whom in your church gets overlooked. Wait for them, honor them, and include them.

Pray that your church's worship would reflect the gospel in both order and love.

On a point where Christians disagree, ask how you can listen first.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you imitate those who imitate Christ.
- Ask him to order your worship.
- Thank him for making men and women for one another.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 110

"So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love."

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

DAY 767 · WEEK 110

1 Corinthians 12:1-14:40

Spiritual gifts; one body; love supreme

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 88 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 12:1-14:40. These three chapters form one argument about spiritual gifts. Read chapter 13 in its place, not in isolation: it sits between two chapters on gifts and explains how they are to be used. Notice the body in chapter 12, love in chapter 13, and order in chapter 14.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Corinthians were eager for spiritual gifts, especially the dramatic ones like tongues. But their use of gifts had become a source of pride, rivalry, and disorder in worship. Paul takes the opportunity to teach about the nature and purpose of the Spirit's gifts. Chapter 13 is not a stand-alone poem on love for weddings, although it is often read there. It is a rebuke and a remedy for a church that valued display over love.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "No one can say Jesus is Lord except in the Holy Spirit" (12:3).
2. "To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good" (12:7).
3. "For just as the body is one and has many members, and all the members of the body, though many, are one body, so it is with Christ" (12:12).
4. "If one member suffers, all suffer together; if one member is honored, all rejoice together" (12:26).
5. "If I speak in the tongues of men and of angels, but have not love, I am a noisy gong or a clanging cymbal" (13:1).
6. "Love is patient and kind; love does not envy or boast; it is not arrogant or rude" (13:4).

7. “So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love” (13:13).

8. “But all things should be done decently and in order” (14:40).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with a test. Pagans were led astray to mute idols. By contrast, “no one speaking in the Spirit of God ever says Jesus is accursed, and no one can say Jesus is Lord except in the Holy Spirit.” Every believer has the Spirit, shown by confessing Christ as Lord. Then comes the Trinity: “There are varieties of gifts, but the same Spirit; and there are varieties of service, but the same Lord; and there are varieties of activities, but it is the same God who empowers them all in everyone.” The gifts are for “the common good,” not for private status. Paul lists wisdom, knowledge, faith, healing, miracles, prophecy, distinguishing of spirits, tongues, and interpretation, all empowered by one and the same Spirit, “who apportions to each one individually as he wills.”

He then pictures the church as a body. “Just as the body is one and has many members… so it is with Christ. For in one Spirit we were all baptized into one body, Jews or Greeks, slaves or free.” The foot cannot say it is not part of the body because it is not a hand. The eye cannot say to the hand, “I have no need of you.” God has so composed the body, giving greater honor to the part that lacked it, that there may be no division. “If one member suffers, all suffer together; if one member is honored, all rejoice together. Now you are the body of Christ and individually members of it.” He lists the offices again: apostles, prophets, teachers, miracle workers, healers, helpers, administrators, tongues. “And I will show you a still more excellent way.”

That way is love. Without it, the most impressive gifts are noise. Tongues, prophecy, knowledge, faith that moves mountains, giving all I have, even martyrdom: “if I have not love, I gain nothing.” Then the description: love is patient and kind; does not envy or boast; is not arrogant or rude; does not insist on its own way; is not irritable or resentful; does not rejoice at wrongdoing, but rejoices with the truth. It bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things. Read these as a portrait of Christ, and a mirror for ourselves. “Love never ends.” Prophecies will pass away, tongues will cease, knowledge will vanish. Now we see in a mirror dimly, but then face to face. “So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love.”

Chapter 14 applies the principle. Pursue love, and desire the spiritual gifts, especially prophecy, because it builds up the church. Tongues, unless interpreted, edify only the speaker. “In church I would rather speak five words with my mind in order to instruct others, than ten thousand words in a tongue.” The aim is building up. Women and men should keep

order: “God is not a God of confusion but of peace.” Verses 34 to 35 on women being silent have been understood in different ways: as a local issue of disruptive questions, as a restriction on weighing prophecy, or as a quotation of a Corinthian slogan. “But all things should be done decently and in order.”

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 2 describes the Spirit at Pentecost. Romans 12:3-8 and Ephesians 4:1-16 also treat gifts and the body. John 13:34-35 gives the new commandment of love. Colossians 3:14 says above all put on love. 1 John 4:7-21 says God is love. Galatians 5:22-23 lists the fruit of the Spirit. Matthew 22:37-40 sums up the law as love. 1 Peter 4:10-11 speaks of using gifts to serve others. Philippians 2:1-4 teaches humility. 2 Corinthians 3:18 and 5:7 speak of seeing now and then.

STEP 6

Application

Read chapter 13 and replace the word “love” with your own name. Where does it not fit? Ask Christ, who does fit, to make it true of you.

Ask what gift God gave you for the common good. Offer it this week.

Honor a member of your church who is less visible, like the weaker parts of the body.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank the Holy Spirit for giving each believer gifts for the common good.
- Ask him to make you content as part of the body.
- Ask him to make love supreme in your gifts.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 110

“So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love.”

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

DAY 768 · WEEK 110

1 Corinthians 12:1-31; Romans 12:3-8; Ephesians 4:11-16

Spiritual Gifts and the Body of Christ

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 12:1-31, Romans 12:3-8, and Ephesians 4:11-16. Today is a doctrinal pause on spiritual gifts and the body of Christ. Notice who gives the gifts, what they are for, and how they work together.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Three letters, three lists, one body. Paul wrote to Corinth, to Rome, and to Ephesus, each time teaching that every believer has a place in the body of Christ. Today we step back from the details of Corinth to see the overall teaching on gifts. This is also an area where evangelical Christians hold different views, especially about miraculous gifts, so it is important to learn the basics and to treat each other kindly.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Now there are varieties of gifts, but the same Spirit” (1 Corinthians 12:4).
2. “To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good” (1 Corinthians 12:7).
3. “All these are empowered by one and the same Spirit, who apportions to each one individually as he wills” (1 Corinthians 12:11).
4. “The eye cannot say to the hand, I have no need of you” (1 Corinthians 12:21).
5. “Not to think of himself more highly than he ought to think” (Romans 12:3).
6. “Having gifts that differ according to the grace given to us, let us use them” (Romans 12:6).

7. “To equip the saints for the work of ministry, for building up the body of Christ” (Ephesians 4:12).

8. “Makes the body grow so that it builds itself up in love” (Ephesians 4:16).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

A spiritual gift is a capacity given by the Holy Spirit to a believer for serving others and building up the church. The Greek word is charisma, from charis (grace): a gift of grace. Three truths hold throughout the New Testament. First, gifts are given by the Spirit, not earned. “He apportions to each one individually as he wills.” Second, every believer has at least one gift: “To each is given.” No one is without a role. Third, gifts are for the common good, not personal status. They are tools for service, not trophies.

The lists in the New Testament are not exhaustive. 1 Corinthians 12 includes wisdom, knowledge, faith, healing, miracles, prophecy, discernment, tongues, and interpretation. Romans 12 adds serving, teaching, exhorting, giving, leading, and mercy. Ephesians 4 names gifted people given to the church: apostles, prophets, evangelists, shepherds, and teachers. 1 Peter 4 divides them into speaking and serving gifts. We see that gifts are as varied as the needs of the body.

Christians disagree about some gifts. Continuationists hold that all gifts, including prophecy, healing, and tongues, continue today. Cessationists hold that the miraculous sign gifts and the foundational office of apostle ceased when the New Testament was completed. Others take a position between them, expecting God to work miraculously while being cautious about claims. All agree that the Spirit is active today, that Scripture is the final authority and is complete, that gifts must be tested by the word, and that love is greater than any gift.

The body image is the center of the doctrine. A body has many parts, each necessary, none self-sufficient. The weaker parts are indispensable. The purpose is edification: “to equip the saints for the work of ministry, for building up the body of Christ,” until we all attain to the unity of the faith and the knowledge of the Son of God, to mature manhood. Pastors and teachers are not to do all the ministry; they equip the saints to do it. The result is a church that grows “in love.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

In 1 Corinthians 12, the foundation is the Trinity: the same Spirit, the same Lord, the same God. Diversity springs from unity. Next, purpose: “for the common good.” A gift that is not shared has missed its purpose. Third, Paul addresses two opposite attitudes. Pride says, “I do

not need you." Inferiority says, "I do not belong." Both are corrected by the body image. If the whole body were an eye, where would be the hearing? God arranged the members as he chose.

Romans 12:3 brings humility: "By the grace given to me I say to everyone among you not to think of himself more highly than he ought to think, but to think with sober judgment, each according to the measure of faith that God has assigned." We have received our gifts; we do not deserve them. Then the diversity: prophecy "in proportion to our faith," service, teaching, exhortation, giving "with generosity," leading "with zeal," mercy "with cheerfulness." Each gift is paired with a way of using it well.

Ephesians 4 shows how Christ is the source: "When he ascended on high he led a host of captives, and he gave gifts to men." Christ gave to the church leaders who equip. "Until we all attain to the unity of the faith… so that we may no longer be children, tossed to and fro by the waves and carried about by every wind of doctrine." Instead, "speaking the truth in love, we are to grow up in every way into him who is the head, into Christ, from whom the whole body, joined and held together by every joint with which it is equipped, when each part is working properly, makes the body grow so that it builds itself up in love."

If you are a believer, you have a gift. Find it by serving in your local church, asking others where they see God's work through you, and trying things. Do not wait for a certainty. You cannot fully know your gift until you use it. And remember the chapter that follows 1 Corinthians 12: without love, even the best gift is nothing.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 6:1-7 shows the church appointing servants. Exodus 31:1-6 speaks of Bezalel being filled with the Spirit for craftsmanship. 1 Peter 4:10-11 speaks of being good stewards of God's varied grace. Psalm 68:18 is quoted in Ephesians 4:8. Colossians 2:19 speaks of the whole body knit together. 1 Thessalonians 5:19-22 says to test everything. 1 Corinthians 14:1-5 compares tongues and prophecy. Hebrews 2:4 mentions gifts of the Holy Spirit distributed according to his will. Matthew 25:14-30 is the parable of the talents.

STEP 6

Application

Write down the ways you serve your local church now. If you have none, pick one place to start.

Ask two people who know you what they see as your strength in serving others.

Thank someone whose gifts are different from yours.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank the Holy Spirit for gifts given to every believer.

Ask him to show you what you have been given and how to use it.

Ask him to help you honor others' gifts.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 110

"So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love."

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

DAY 769 · WEEK 110

Psalm 111

Great are the works of the LORD

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 111. It is one of the alphabetic acrostic psalms, with each line beginning with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet. Read it as a hymn of remembering God's works, and notice its link to the Lord's Supper and the church's gathering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 111 and 112 are a pair. Both begin with "Praise the LORD" and are acrostics, each with twenty-two short lines. Psalm 111 describes God and his works; Psalm 112 describes the person who fears him and reflects his character. Psalm 111 is sung in the congregation: "in the company of the upright, in the congregation." It fits our study of the church's worship and the meal of remembrance.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! I will give thanks to the LORD with my whole heart, in the company of the upright, in the congregation" (v. 1).
2. "Great are the works of the LORD, studied by all who delight in them" (v. 2).
3. "Full of splendor and majesty is his work, and his righteousness endures forever" (v. 3).
4. "He has caused his wondrous works to be remembered; the LORD is gracious and merciful" (v. 4).
5. "He provides food for those who fear him; he remembers his covenant forever" (v. 5).
6. "He sent redemption to his people; he has commanded his covenant forever" (v. 9).
7. "Holy and awesome is his name!" (v. 9).

8 “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom; all those who practice it have a good understanding” (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with whole-hearted thanksgiving, offered in the congregation. Worship is personal and corporate. Verse 2 says the works of the LORD are great and “studied by all who delight in them.” We are invited not only to admire God’s works but to study them. The more we look, the more we see his splendor and majesty. “His righteousness endures forever.”

Verse 4 is the heart: “He has caused his wondrous works to be remembered; the LORD is gracious and merciful.” God designs memorials. He gave Israel the Passover, the feasts, and the stones of remembrance, and he has given the church the Lord’s Supper. We tend to forget, so God gives us ways to remember. The psalm’s God is “gracious and merciful,” echoing Exodus 34:6. Verse 5: “He provides food for those who fear him; he remembers his covenant forever.” This recalls manna in the wilderness, and our daily bread. Notice that God remembers his covenant, even as he asks us to remember his works.

The next verses speak of power and justice. “He has shown his people the power of his works, in giving them the inheritance of the nations.” “The works of his hands are faithful and just; all his precepts are trustworthy; they are established forever and ever, to be performed with faithfulness and uprightness.” His commands are as reliable as his deeds.

Then the great verse: “He sent redemption to his people; he has commanded his covenant forever. Holy and awesome is his name!” Redemption is the exodus in the original context. For Christians it is also the cross, where the Lord Jesus redeemed us by his blood, establishing the new covenant. The Supper is the memorial of that redemption. And the name of the LORD is holy and awesome (the word is “fearful,” to be revered).

The psalm ends with a proverb that is also the key to the whole Bible’s wisdom literature: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom; all those who practice it have a good understanding. His praise endures forever!” Wisdom begins with reverent awe before the God who has acted. This connects with the opening chapters of 1 Corinthians, where the wisdom of God is found in the cross.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 34:6-7 describes God as gracious and merciful. Exodus 12:14 and Deuteronomy 8:2 speak of remembering. Psalm 105 retells God’s works. Luke 22:19 says “Do this in remembrance of me.” Proverbs 1:7 and 9:10 say the fear of the LORD is the beginning of

wisdom. Luke 1:68 and 1:49 speak of redemption and the holy name. Revelation 15:3-4 sings "Great and amazing are your deeds." Psalm 112 is the companion psalm. Hebrews 9:15 speaks of redemption under the new covenant.

STEP 6

Application

Write down three of the LORD's works in your life and give thanks in the congregation of your family or friends.

At your next Communion, pray verse 4: he has caused his wondrous works to be remembered.

Study one of God's works this week, in creation or in Scripture, and delight in it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God with your whole heart.
- Tell him about works of his that you want to remember.
- Ask him to give you the fear of the LORD that is the beginning of wisdom.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 110

"So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love."

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

DAY 770 · WEEK 110

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Corinthians 13:13 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love."

1 CORINTHIANS 13:13

REST

Meditation

This verse is the last line of the love chapter, and it summarizes a chapter about what lasts.

"So now." Paul has described gifts that will pass away: prophecies, tongues, knowledge. They are temporary scaffolding. "Now" marks the present time between Christ's first and second comings.

"Faith, hope, and love abide." These three remain. Faith trusts God's promises. Hope looks forward to what he has promised. Love gives itself to God and others. Each is a gift of the Spirit, and each is fixed on Christ.

"These three." They go together. Faith without love is dead; hope without faith is wishful; love without hope grows weary. The Christian life is a life of all three.

“But the greatest of these is love.” Why is love greatest? Because faith will become sight, and hope will be fulfilled, but love will last forever. God himself is love. In heaven, we won’t need to believe what we see or hope for what we have, but we will love for all eternity.

When you wonder what matters most in the church or in your life, say this verse. Love is the measure of all.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read more of 1 Corinthians and saw how Paul answered a church’s questions with the gospel. In chapters 8 to 10, you learned how to use freedom: knowledge puffs up but love builds up, and whatever we do we should do for the glory of God. A doctrinal pause on the Lord’s Supper taught that Jesus gave his church a meal of remembrance, proclamation, and hope, and that we come in repentance and unity. In chapter 11, you read about order in worship and the sin of dividing the body at the Lord’s table. Chapters 12 to 14 gave the great teaching on spiritual gifts: one Spirit, many gifts, one body, and the more excellent way of love. A second doctrinal pause considered the gifts and the body of Christ. Psalm 111 called us to remember and give thanks for the works of the LORD, who sent redemption to his people.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says love is greater than faith and hope. What does it look like to treat love as the most important measure of your spiritual life, and not gifts, knowledge, or activity?

The Lord’s Supper proclaims Christ’s death until he comes. How might you prepare differently the next time you take Communion?

What gift has God given you for the common good of your church? Who in your church needs what you can offer?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for the meal of remembrance.

Thank him for gifts he gives his church.

Ask him to teach you to love as he loves.

DAY 771 · WEEK 111

Psalm 112

Blessed is the man who fears the LORD

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 112. It is the companion to Psalm 111. Where Psalm 111 described the LORD, this psalm describes the person who fears the LORD, and the person turns out to be like him. Paul quotes verse 9 in 2 Corinthians 9:9.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 112 is also an acrostic, with twenty-two short lines. It describes the blessed person who fears the LORD and delights in his commandments. The pairing with Psalm 111 is intentional: many phrases are repeated, like "his righteousness endures forever." What is said of God is also said of the godly person. This is the Bible's picture of becoming like the one we worship. It also anticipates Paul's teaching about generosity at the end of the unit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Blessed is the man who fears the LORD, who greatly delights in his commandments!" (v. 1).
2. "Light dawns in the darkness for the upright; he is gracious, merciful, and righteous" (v. 4).
3. "It is well with the man who deals generously and lends; who conducts his affairs with justice" (v. 5).
4. "For the righteous will never be moved; he will be remembered forever" (v. 6).
5. "He is not afraid of bad news; his heart is firm, trusting in the LORD" (v. 7).
6. "His heart is steady; he will not be afraid" (v. 8).
7. "He has distributed freely; he has given to the poor" (v. 9).

8 “His righteousness endures forever; his horn is exalted in honor” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a beatitude: “Blessed is the man who fears the LORD, who greatly delights in his commandments!” Fear and delight go together. The fear of the LORD is not terror but reverence, and obedience is a joy, not a burden. The blessing extends to the next generation: “His offspring will be mighty in the land.” Wealth and righteousness are mentioned, but the focus is on the character that lasts: “his righteousness endures forever.” This is the same phrase used of God in Psalm 111:3. The godly person reflects the character of God.

Verse 4 gives the surprising line: “Light dawns in the darkness for the upright; he is gracious, merciful, and righteous.” Again, the words “gracious and merciful” are used of God in Psalm 111:4. The person who fears the LORD is a light for others in dark times, and he receives light himself. Then comes generosity: “It is well with the man who deals generously and lends; who conducts his affairs with justice.” Faith expresses itself in the use of money and in fairness.

Verse 6 says “The righteous will never be moved; he will be remembered forever.” This echoes the stability of the one who trusts in the LORD. Verse 7: “He is not afraid of bad news; his heart is firm, trusting in the LORD.” How many of us live in fear of bad news? The believer’s security rests on a faithful God, not on good circumstances. This does not mean no bad news will come, but that it cannot shake us. “His heart is steady; he will not be afraid, until he looks in triumph on his adversaries.”

Verse 9 is the center: “He has distributed freely; he has given to the poor; his righteousness endures forever; his horn is exalted in honor.” Paul quotes this verse in 2 Corinthians 9:9 to encourage the Corinthians to give to the poor believers in Jerusalem. Generosity is a sign of righteousness. And God, who supplies seed to the sower, will multiply your seed for sowing and increase the harvest of your righteousness.

The psalm ends with a contrast: “The wicked man sees it and is angry; he gnashes his teeth and melts away; the desire of the wicked will perish!” Those who reject God’s ways cannot stand the light of the righteous. But the one who fears the LORD will not be shaken.

In the end, the one who perfectly fits this psalm is Christ, who feared the LORD, delighted in his commands, gave freely to the poor, and has been exalted in honor. We are being made like him.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Corinthians 9:6-15 quotes verse 9 in the context of giving. Psalm 111 is the companion. Psalm 1 also describes the blessed man. Proverbs 19:17 says whoever is generous to the poor lends to the LORD. Matthew 5:14-16 calls us the light of the world. Luke 6:35-36 says be merciful as your Father is merciful. Ephesians 5:1 says be imitators of God. 1 Timothy 6:17-19 commands the rich to be generous. Isaiah 26:3 speaks of perfect peace for those whose mind is stayed on the LORD.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where bad news makes you afraid. Pray verse 7 and give that worry to God.

Give something to someone in need this week, quietly. Do it with the attitude of verse 9.

Notice where your character looks like the character of God. Thank him. Notice where it doesn't. Ask him to change it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to make you gracious, merciful, and righteous.

Tell him you want to fear him and delight in his commandments.

Ask him to give you generosity.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 111

"For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures."

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

DAY 772 · WEEK 111

Psalm 133

How good and pleasant when brothers dwell in unity

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Psalm · 3 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 133. It is three verses long. It is a Song of Ascents, sung by pilgrims on their way to Jerusalem. Read it slowly twice and picture the two images: oil and dew.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 133 is a psalm of David and belongs to the pilgrim songs. When Israelite families came together from all over the land for the festivals in Jerusalem, they experienced the unity of the people of God. In the context of 1 Corinthians, a church torn by factions, this psalm is a picture of what Paul longed to see. Unity is not an optional extra but a gift and a command.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Behold, how good and pleasant it is when brothers dwell in unity!” (v. 1).
2. “When brothers dwell in unity” (v. 1).
3. “It is like the precious oil on the head” (v. 2).
4. “Running down on the beard, on the beard of Aaron” (v. 2).
5. “Running down on the collar of his robes!” (v. 2).
6. “It is like the dew of Hermon” (v. 3).
7. “Which falls on the mountains of Zion” (v. 3).
8. “For there the LORD has commanded the blessing, life forevermore” (v. 3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with an exclamation: “Behold, how good and pleasant it is when brothers dwell in unity!” The words “good” and “pleasant” mean something that is both right and delightful. We often think of unity as duty. The psalm says it is a delight. The word translated “brothers” includes the whole family of God. The unity described is among those who “dwell together,” sharing life.

Then two pictures. First, precious oil poured on the head of Aaron the high priest at his consecration (Exodus 29:7, Leviticus 8:12). It ran down on the beard and the collar of his robes. Oil was abundant, fragrant, and set apart for holy use. Unity is like holy oil that flows down from the head over the whole body. It is a lavish, overflowing gift. For Christians, the Head is Christ, and the Spirit he sends is poured out on the whole body. The oil of anointing reaches to the collar and beyond: to every member.

The second picture is dew from Mount Hermon, the tallest mountain in the region, covered in snow and heavy with moisture. In the dry summers, dew was life for the crops. The dew of Hermon falls on the mountains of Zion, which are much farther south and drier. The picture is of refreshment coming down from above to fertilize a dry land. Unity is life-giving.

“For there the LORD has commanded the blessing, life forevermore.” Notice that the blessing is “commanded.” God designates unity as the place where he gives life. In Christ’s prayer in John 17, he asked that his followers be one, so that the world may believe. And Paul calls the Corinthians to the same unity: “that all of you agree, and that there be no divisions among you.”

We should not romanticize unity. It requires forgiveness, patience, and humility. It does not mean agreeing on everything, but sharing the same Lord, the same gospel, and the same Spirit. Ephesians 4:3 says to be “eager to maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace.” The unity is already ours in Christ; our job is to guard and display it.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 29:7 and Leviticus 8:12 describe the anointing of Aaron. Deuteronomy 33:28 mentions dew. John 17:20-23 is Jesus’ prayer for unity. Ephesians 4:1-6 urges us to maintain unity. Colossians 3:12-15 describes the bond of perfect harmony. Philippians 2:1-4 calls for being of one mind. Acts 2:42-47 and 4:32 describe the early church’s unity. 1 Corinthians 1:10 and 12:12-26 treat unity in Corinth. Romans 15:5-6 prays for harmony. Hebrews 13:1 says let brotherly love continue.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a fellow believer you are at odds with. Take a step to be reconciled.

Pray for the unity of your church by name: elders, volunteers, and members.

Thank God for a time when you tasted unity with others, and ask for more.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the unity of his people.

Ask him to pour out his Spirit like precious oil on your church.

Pray for peace in a specific relationship.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 111

"For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures."

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

DAY 773 · WEEK 111

1 Corinthians 15:1-58

The resurrection, the gospel's foundation

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 15:1-58. This is the great resurrection chapter. Read in four parts: the gospel and the witnesses (1-11), the necessity of the resurrection (12-34), the nature of the resurrection body (35-49), and the victory (50-58). The next two days are doctrinal pauses on this chapter, so today read for the shape of the argument.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Some in Corinth were saying "there is no resurrection of the dead." They may have accepted that the soul lives on but not that the body will be raised, a common Greek view. Paul responds with the greatest defense of the resurrection in the Bible. If there is no resurrection, there is no gospel. This chapter is the climax of the letter, and the teaching affects how Christians face death, suffering, and daily work.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "That Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures" (15:3).
2. "But by the grace of God I am what I am, and his grace toward me was not in vain" (15:10).
3. "And if Christ has not been raised, then our preaching is in vain and your faith is in vain" (15:14).
4. "But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep" (15:20).
5. "For as in Adam all die, so also in Christ shall all be made alive" (15:22).
6. "The last enemy to be destroyed is death" (15:26).

7. “O death, where is your victory? O death, where is your sting?” (15:55).
8. “Therefore, my beloved brothers, be steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, knowing that in the Lord your labor is not in vain” (15:58).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with the gospel: “I would remind you, brothers, of the gospel I preached to you, which you received, in which you stand, and by which you are being saved.” Then he gives what is likely one of the earliest creeds of the church: “For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures, and that he appeared to Cephas, then to the twelve. Then he appeared to more than five hundred brothers at one time, most of whom are still alive, though some have fallen asleep. Then he appeared to James, then to all the apostles. Last of all, as to one untimely born, he appeared also to me.” The resurrection is rooted in history and eyewitness testimony. Paul invites the Corinthians to check with the living witnesses. Notice “in accordance with the Scriptures” twice. The gospel is the fulfillment of the Old Testament.

Then the logic of chapters 12 to 34. If there is no resurrection of the dead, then Christ has not been raised; if Christ has not been raised, our preaching is in vain, your faith is in vain, we are misrepresenting God, you are still in your sins, and those who have died in Christ have perished. “If in Christ we have hope in this life only, we are of all people most to be pitied.” But the truth is “Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep.” The firstfruits is the first part of the harvest, guaranteeing the rest. His resurrection is the start of the general resurrection. The contrast with Adam: “as in Adam all die, so also in Christ shall all be made alive.” Then the order: Christ the firstfruits, then at his coming those who belong to him, then the end, when he delivers the kingdom to God the Father after destroying every rule, authority, and power. “The last enemy to be destroyed is death.”

Paul answers the question about the kind of body: “How are the dead raised? With what kind of body do they come?” He uses a seed: what you sow is not the body that is to be, but a bare kernel. God gives it a body as he has chosen. There are different kinds of bodies, glories of sun, moon, and stars. “So it is with the resurrection of the dead. What is sown is perishable; what is raised is imperishable. It is sown in dishonor; it is raised in glory. It is sown in weakness; it is raised in power. It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body.” Just as we have borne the image of the man of dust (Adam), we shall bear the image of the man of heaven (Christ).

The climax: “Behold! I tell you a mystery. We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet.” The dead will be raised imperishable, and we shall be changed. “Death is swallowed up in victory. O death, where is your victory? O death, where is your sting?” The sting of death is sin, and the power of sin is the law, “but thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.”

And the practical conclusion: “Therefore, my beloved brothers, be steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, knowing that in the Lord your labor is not in vain.” Because of the resurrection, everything we do for the Lord matters forever.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 24:13-49 and John 20 to 21 describe the resurrection appearances. Acts 2:24-36 and 17:30-32 preach the resurrection. Genesis 3 and Romans 5:12-21 contrast Adam and Christ. Psalm 110:1 and 8:6 are quoted in verses 25 to 27. Isaiah 25:8 and Hosea 13:14 are quoted in verses 54 to 55. Philippians 3:20-21 describes the transformation of our bodies. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 describes the coming of the Lord and the resurrection. Daniel 12:2 predicts the resurrection. Revelation 20:11-21:5 describes the final victory.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize 1 Corinthians 15:3-4 as a summary of the gospel.

Think of someone grieving a loved one who died in Christ. Share with them verse 58 or verse 20.

Ask what “work of the Lord” you could do this week knowing it is not in vain.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the gospel of first importance: Christ died, was buried, and was raised.
- Tell him what the resurrection means to you.
- Ask him to make you steadfast and abounding in his work.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 111

“For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures.”

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

DAY 774 · WEEK 111

1 Corinthians 15:1-28; Matthew 28:1-10

The Resurrection of Christ

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 15:1-28 and Matthew 28:1-10. Today is a doctrinal pause on the resurrection of Christ. Notice the evidence, the meaning, and the consequences of the empty tomb.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The resurrection of Jesus is the central claim of Christianity. Without it, as Paul says, the faith collapses. The four Gospels each tell of the empty tomb, and Paul lists the appearances. Matthew's account is brief and vivid: an earthquake, an angel, and two women who meet the risen Lord. Today we think about what the resurrection of Christ is, why it matters, and how we know.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He is not here, for he has risen, as he said" (Matthew 28:6).
2. "And they came up and took hold of his feet and worshiped him" (Matthew 28:9).
3. "That he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures" (1 Corinthians 15:4).
4. "Then he appeared to more than five hundred brothers at one time, most of whom are still alive" (1 Corinthians 15:6).
5. "And if Christ has not been raised, your faith is futile and you are still in your sins" (1 Corinthians 15:17).

6. “But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep” (1 Corinthians 15:20).
7. “For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet” (1 Corinthians 15:25).
8. “That God may be all in all” (1 Corinthians 15:28).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The resurrection of Jesus is the historical event in which God raised the crucified Jesus from the dead on the third day, in a real, physical, glorified body, never to die again. It was not a resuscitation, like Lazarus, who died again. Jesus was raised to a new kind of life: the tomb was empty, and yet his body had new powers. He could pass through closed doors, but he ate fish and invited Thomas to touch his wounds.

The evidence is strong. The tomb was empty, and Jesus’ enemies never produced a body. The women, whose testimony was not prized in that culture, were the first witnesses. He appeared to individuals, to groups, to the Twelve, and to more than five hundred at once. The disciples were transformed from frightened deserters to bold witnesses, willing to die for what they had seen. Even Paul, the persecutor, and James, the skeptical brother of Jesus, were changed. The earliest church worshiped on Sunday, the day of the resurrection.

The meaning is vast. First, the resurrection vindicates Jesus: he is the Son of God (Romans 1:4). Second, it confirms that his death was accepted as payment for sin: “raised for our justification” (Romans 4:25). Third, it defeats death: he is the firstfruits, guaranteeing our resurrection. Fourth, it inaugurates the new creation: the age to come has begun, even though it is not yet complete. Fifth, it establishes his reign: he is seated at the right hand of the Father, and he must reign until all enemies are subdued.

Christians affirm the bodily resurrection, and it is non-negotiable. Some modern theologians have spoken of a “spiritual” resurrection or a change in the disciples’ faith, but the New Testament insists on an empty tomb and a real, physical body. Paul says without the resurrection our faith is futile. But “in fact Christ has been raised.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Matthew 28, two women come to the tomb at dawn. There is a great earthquake as an angel rolls back the stone and sits on it. His appearance is like lightning. The guards shake and become like dead men. The angel says, “Do not be afraid, for I know that you seek Jesus who was crucified. He is not here, for he has risen, as he said. Come, see the place where he lay.” Then, “go quickly and tell his disciples that he has risen from the dead.” The women leave with fear and great joy. Jesus meets them: “Greetings!” They take hold of his feet and

worship him. They touch him, which shows he is not a ghost. And he says: “Do not be afraid; go and tell my brothers to go to Galilee, and there they will see me.” Notice that he calls his frightened disciples “my brothers,” even after they deserted him.

Paul in 1 Corinthians 15 argues from the evidence and then from the implications. Verses 12 to 19 form a chain: if the dead are not raised, Christ is not raised; if Christ is not raised, preaching is empty and faith is futile; we are still in our sins; those who died in Christ are lost; we are the most pitiable of people. But the next verse breaks the chain: “But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep.”

In verses 20 to 28, Paul shows the cosmic scope. Death came through a man, and the resurrection of the dead also comes through a man. In Adam all die; in Christ all will be made alive. Each in his own order: Christ the firstfruits, then those who belong to Christ at his coming. Then comes the end, when he delivers the kingdom to God the Father after destroying every rule and every authority and power. “For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. The last enemy to be destroyed is death.” Christ’s present reign is the fulfillment of Psalm 110. He reigns now, and the victory over death is certain. At the end, the Son is subjected to the Father, in a loving order within the Trinity, so that God may be all in all.

The resurrection is not simply a doctrine to affirm but a reality to live in. Because Christ is risen, we have forgiveness, hope, and purpose. We can face death without despair.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 16:8-11 predicts the Holy One not seeing corruption (see Acts 2:25-32). Isaiah 53:10-12 foresees the servant’s vindication. Hosea 6:2 mentions the third day. Matthew 12:38-40 is the sign of Jonah. Luke 24 and John 20 to 21 record other appearances. Acts 1:3, 2:32, and 10:40-41 speak of witnesses. Romans 1:4, 4:25, and 6:4-5 give the meaning. Philippians 3:10 speaks of knowing the power of his resurrection. 1 Peter 1:3-5 speaks of a living hope. Revelation 1:17-18 shows the risen Christ holding the keys of death.

STEP 6

Application

Read the account of the resurrection in one Gospel (Matthew 28, Mark 16, Luke 24, or John 20) and notice the details.

Share the hope of the resurrection with someone who is grieving or afraid of death.

On Sunday, remember that you gather on the day of the resurrection.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise Jesus that he has risen as he said.

Thank him for the hope the resurrection gives.

Tell him what you want to say to someone about it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 111

"For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures."

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

DAY 775 · WEEK 111

1 Corinthians 15:35-58; Daniel 12:1-3; John 5:28-29

The Resurrection of the Dead

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 15:35-58, Daniel 12:1-3, and John 5:28-29. Today is a doctrinal pause on the resurrection of the dead. Notice the nature of the resurrection body and the two destinies.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday we studied the resurrection of Christ. Today we look at his promise that his people will be raised. The Christian hope is not an immortal soul floating in a spiritual realm, though believers who die are with Christ (see Day 779). The final hope is bodily resurrection and a new creation. The Old Testament hints at it, and Jesus taught it. Paul's answer to the question "With what kind of body do they come?" is one of the most important passages for the Christian view of the future.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt" (Daniel 12:2).
2. "And those who are wise shall shine like the brightness of the sky above" (Daniel 12:3).
3. "An hour is coming when all who are in the tombs will hear his voice and come out" (John 5:28-29).
4. "What is sown is perishable; what is raised is imperishable" (1 Corinthians 15:42).
5. "It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body" (1 Corinthians 15:44).

6. “Just as we have borne the image of the man of dust, we shall also bear the image of the man of heaven” (1 Corinthians 15:49).
7. “We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet” (1 Corinthians 15:51-52).
8. “Death is swallowed up in victory” (1 Corinthians 15:54).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Bible teaches that all the dead will be raised bodily, the righteous to eternal life and the unrighteous to judgment. This is the general resurrection. Daniel 12:2 is the clearest Old Testament statement: “Many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt.” Jesus affirms it in John 5:28-29: all who are in the tombs will hear his voice and come out, “those who have done good to the resurrection of life, and those who have done evil to the resurrection of judgment.” Paul told Felix he had a hope in “a resurrection of both the just and the unjust” (Acts 24:15).

For believers, the resurrection body will be like Christ’s. Paul uses the seed analogy: there is continuity, because the same person is raised, and transformation, because the new body is much greater. It will be imperishable, glorious, powerful, and “spiritual” (that is, animated by the Spirit, not immaterial). Philippians 3:21 says Christ “will transform our lowly body to be like his glorious body.” We will recognize one another and be recognizable. The final state is not a disembodied existence, but a new heaven and new earth, where the redeemed live in resurrected bodies in the presence of God.

Christians have different views about the timing and sequence of the end, including whether there is a literal thousand-year reign of Christ (the millennium), whether the resurrection of the righteous and the unrighteous happen at the same time, and how Israel fits in. Premillennialists, amillennialists, and postmillennialists all affirm Christ’s personal, visible return, the bodily resurrection, the final judgment, and the new creation. The difference lies in how to read Revelation 20 and related passages. We should hold our views on timing with humility.

The practical effect of the doctrine is profound. We do not fear the grave. We treat our bodies with dignity. We care for the physical world and for the suffering. We grieve with hope. And we work with confidence, because the final word belongs to God.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul anticipates two questions: “How are the dead raised? With what kind of body do they come?” He answers with an analogy: “What you sow does not come to life unless it dies. And what you sow is not the body that is to be, but a bare kernel.” The seed dies and rises as a plant. God gives it a body as he has chosen. There is continuity and difference. The glories of earthly and heavenly bodies differ, as the sun, moon, and stars differ in glory.

Then the four contrasts: “What is sown is perishable; what is raised is imperishable. It is sown in dishonor; it is raised in glory. It is sown in weakness; it is raised in power. It is sown a natural body; it is raised a spiritual body.” Burial is sowing. The body goes into the ground like a seed. The resurrection body is not less physical than the present body, but more: it is fitted for life in the new creation, under the Spirit’s power.

Paul continues, “Thus it is written, The first man Adam became a living being; the last Adam became a life-giving spirit.” Christ is the model and source of our resurrection. “Just as we have borne the image of the man of dust, we shall also bear the image of the man of heaven.” Flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God, nor does the perishable inherit the imperishable. A change is needed.

Then the mystery: not all will die, but all will be changed “in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet.” The perishable body must put on the imperishable, and the mortal body immortality. When this happens, the Scripture will be fulfilled: “Death is swallowed up in victory.” Paul quotes Isaiah 25:8 and Hosea 13:14 and taunts death: “O death, where is your victory? O death, where is your sting?” The sting of death is sin, and the power of sin is the law. But Christ has dealt with sin, and so the sting is removed.

Daniel 12:3 adds a note of glory: “Those who are wise shall shine like the brightness of the sky above, and those who turn many to righteousness, like the stars forever and ever.” The people of God will shine. Whatever we do now in faithfulness will not be forgotten.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 25:6-9 and 26:19 anticipate the resurrection. Job 19:25-27 declares “I know that my Redeemer lives.” Ezekiel 37:1-14 is the vision of dry bones. Luke 20:27-40 records Jesus on the resurrection. John 11:21-27 records Jesus saying “I am the resurrection and the life.” Romans 8:11, 8:18-25 and 2 Corinthians 4:14 speak of future resurrection. Philippians 3:20-21 describes the transformation. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 comforts the grieving. Revelation 20 to 22 describes the final judgment and new creation.

STEP 6

Application

Treat your body today as something God will raise: care for it, honor it, use it for his service.

If you have lost someone in Christ, read verses 42 to 44 and imagine them in glory.

Thank God that death is swallowed up in victory.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that he will raise the dead.

Tell him what you want to say about death in light of this.

Ask him to keep you steadfast in the meantime.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 111

"For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures."

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

DAY 776 · WEEK 111

1 Corinthians 16:1-24

The collection; final greetings

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 16:1-24. Paul closes with practical matters: the collection, travel plans, coworkers, and greetings. Notice the way he combines practical details with spiritual urgency.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the soaring heights of chapter 15, Paul returns to earth. Chapter 16 reminds us that ordinary church life, such as money, schedules, hospitality, and greetings, is part of the work of the gospel. The collection is for the poor believers in Jerusalem, a project that Paul was organizing among the Gentile churches. It was a sign of the unity between Jew and Gentile.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “On the first day of every week, each of you is to put something aside and store it up, as he may prosper” (16:2).
2. “For a wide door for effective work has opened to me, and there are many adversaries” (16:9).
3. “Be watchful, stand firm in the faith, act like men, be strong” (16:13).
4. “Let all that you do be done in love” (16:14).
5. “They have devoted themselves to the service of the saints” (16:15).
6. “Aquila and Prisca, together with the church in their house, send you hearty greetings in the Lord” (16:19).
7. “Our Lord, come!” (16:22).
8. “The grace of the Lord Jesus be with you” (16:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with the collection for the saints in Jerusalem. He gave the same instructions to the churches of Galatia. “On the first day of every week, each of you is to put something aside and store it up, as he may prosper, so that there will be no collecting when I come.” The pattern: regular, personal, proportionate, and planned. The first day of the week is the day of resurrection and of gathering. Giving belongs with worship. Paul plans to send the gift with approved messengers, ensuring accountability.

His travel plans are flexible and subject to God’s will. He will stay in Ephesus until Pentecost, “for a wide door for effective work has opened to me, and there are many adversaries.” Opportunity and opposition often come together. He asks the Corinthians to receive Timothy without fear, and to send him on in peace. Apollos, who he strongly urged to visit, will come when he has opportunity. Notice that Paul does not control his coworkers; he treats them as partners.

Then a series of short commands, like a sergeant’s orders: “Be watchful, stand firm in the faith, act like men, be strong. Let all that you do be done in love.” This last sentence sums up the whole letter. In a church full of pride, division, and misuse of gifts, love is the controlling principle. Paul commends the household of Stephanas, the first converts in Achaia, who have devoted themselves to the service of the saints. Submit to such people, he says, and to every fellow worker. He is glad of the arrival of Stephanas, Fortunatus, and Achaicus, for they refreshed his spirit.

The greetings are warm. The churches of Asia send greetings. “Aquila and Prisca, together with the church in their house, send you hearty greetings in the Lord.” The early church met in homes. “Greet one another with a holy kiss.” Paul takes the pen in his own hand to sign: “If anyone has no love for the Lord, let him be accursed. Our Lord, come!” The Aramaic word is “Maranatha,” a prayer of the early church for the return of Christ. It reveals the hope behind chapter 15. The letter ends with grace and love: “The grace of the Lord Jesus be with you. My love be with you all in Christ Jesus. Amen.” Despite all the rebukes, Paul ends with love for the church.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 11:27-30, Romans 15:25-29, and 2 Corinthians 8 to 9 speak of the collection. Acts 20:7 shows the church gathering on the first day. Acts 18:1-3, 24-28, and 19:1-10 mention Aquila, Priscilla, Apollos, and Ephesus. 1 Thessalonians 5:12-13 asks to respect those who labor.

Hebrews 13:17 asks to submit to leaders. 1 Peter 5:14 mentions the kiss of love. Revelation 22:20 is “Come, Lord Jesus.” 2 Corinthians 9:6-8 teaches cheerful giving. Philippians 4:15-19 shows the Philippians’ gift.

STEP 6

Application

Decide on a regular, planned amount to give to your church or to the poor, and give it joyfully.

Thank someone in your church who serves quietly, like the household of Stephanas.

Pray “Our Lord, come!” at the end of the day.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the saints who give and serve.

Ask him to help you do all in love.

Pray for someone in your church by name.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 111

“For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures.”

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

DAY 777 · WEEK 111

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Corinthians 15:3-4 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures."

1 CORINTHIANS 15:3-4

REST

Meditation

This is a summary of the gospel, and it was handed down from the earliest days.

"As of first importance." Paul places this message at the top of the list. Many things in the Christian life matter, but some matter most. The death and resurrection of Christ are the foundation.

"What I also received." Paul did not invent the gospel. He received it, probably from the first apostles within a few years of the event, and he delivered it. We too receive and pass on.

"That Christ died for our sins." Notice the three parts: the person (Christ), the event (died), and the purpose (for our sins). His death was not an accident but a substitution, dealing with our guilt.

“In accordance with the Scriptures.” The cross is the fulfillment of what the Old Testament promised, in Isaiah 53, Psalm 22, and the sacrifices.

“That he was buried.” The burial proves he truly died.

“That he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures.” The tomb was empty because Christ was alive. This too was foretold.

When the world offers other messages, say this verse. These two verses are the heart of what we believe.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the end of 1 Corinthians. Chapters 12 to 14 gave Paul’s teaching on spiritual gifts, the body of Christ, and the more excellent way of love, and a doctrinal pause considered the gifts and the unity of the body. Psalms 111 and 112 sang about remembering the works of the LORD and becoming like him, and Psalm 133 pictured the beauty of unity. Chapter 15 gave the resurrection: the gospel of first importance, Christ the firstfruits, the nature of the resurrection body, and the victory over death. Two doctrinal pauses studied the resurrection of Christ and the resurrection of the dead. Chapter 16 closed the letter with the collection, greetings, and the cry “Our Lord, come!”

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul calls the death and resurrection of Christ “of first importance.” What other things in your spiritual life have crowded into that first place? How can you put the gospel back at the center?

The resurrection of Jesus is the firstfruits of the resurrection of believers. How does knowing your body will be raised change how you see aging, illness, or death?

Paul ends his long letter with “Let all that you do be done in love.” Where in your life this week will it be hardest to do everything in love? What will you ask Christ for help with?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that he died for your sins and was raised on the third day.

Tell him what you want to hold on to this week.

Rest in him.

DAY 778 · WEEK 112

2 Corinthians 1:1-3:18

Comfort in suffering; the new covenant ministry

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 64 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Corinthians 1:1-3:18. Paul writes his most personal letter. Notice the comfort in suffering in chapter 1, the aroma of Christ in chapter 2, and the new covenant ministry in chapter 3.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After writing 1 Corinthians, Paul's relationship with the church became strained. He made a painful visit, wrote a severe letter (now lost), and waited anxiously for news from Titus. When Titus brought good news in Macedonia, Paul wrote 2 Corinthians, a letter full of emotion. It defends his ministry against critics who called him weak and unimpressive, and it reveals the heart of a pastor who suffers for his people. Chapters 1 to 3 introduce the main themes: comfort through affliction and the glory of the new covenant.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The Father of mercies and God of all comfort" (1:3).
2. "Indeed, we felt that we had received the sentence of death. But that was to make us rely not on ourselves but on God who raises the dead" (1:9).
3. "For all the promises of God find their Yes in him" (1:20).
4. "Who has also put his seal on us and given us his Spirit in our hearts as a guarantee" (1:22).
5. "You show that you are a letter from Christ delivered by us, written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God, not on tablets of stone but on tablets of human hearts" (3:3).

6. “Who has made us competent to be ministers of a new covenant, not of the letter but of the Spirit. For the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life” (3:6).
7. “Now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom” (3:17).
8. “Beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another” (3:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul opens with a blessing: “Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of mercies and God of all comfort, who comforts us in all our affliction, so that we may be able to comfort those who are in any affliction, with the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God.” Comfort is not a private possession. We receive in order to give. Suffering abounds for Christ, but through Christ comfort abounds too. He describes a recent affliction in Asia that was so severe that they despaired of life. “Indeed, we felt that we had received the sentence of death. But that was to make us rely not on ourselves but on God who raises the dead.” Suffering teaches dependence.

He explains why he did not come to Corinth as planned: he was sparing them. His “Yes” is not “Yes and No.” Then a beautiful statement on the faithfulness of God: “For all the promises of God find their Yes in him. That is why it is through him that we utter our Amen to God for his glory.” Christ is the fulfillment of every promise. It is God who establishes us with you in Christ, anointed us, “put his seal on us and given us his Spirit in our hearts as a guarantee.” The Spirit is the down payment on our inheritance.

Chapter 2 refers to the painful letter written “out of much affliction and anguish of heart and with many tears.” When someone had caused grief, the church disciplined him. Now Paul says it is time to forgive and comfort him, “so that he may not be overwhelmed by excessive sorrow.” Forgiveness protects against Satan’s schemes. Then a picture of triumph: “But thanks be to God, who in Christ always leads us in triumphal procession, and through him spreads the fragrance of the knowledge of him everywhere.” The image is of a Roman victory parade, with incense burning. For some it is the aroma of life; for others, death. “Who is sufficient for these things?” Not Paul, but God.

In chapter 3, Paul defends his credentials. “You yourselves are our letter of recommendation, written on our hearts… a letter from Christ delivered by us, written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God, not on tablets of stone but on tablets of human hearts.” This echoes Ezekiel 36 and Jeremiah 31. Our competence is from God, “who has made us competent to be ministers of a new covenant, not of the letter but of the Spirit. For the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life.” The old covenant, engraved in letters on stone, came with glory, but it was a ministry of death and condemnation, fading. The new covenant ministry of the Spirit and of

righteousness has far greater glory, and it remains. This is a key text for progressive covenantalism: the old covenant was glorious, but it was temporary, and the new covenant exceeds it in glory. Moses put a veil over his face so the Israelites would not gaze at the fading glory. A veil lies over hearts when the old covenant is read, "because only through Christ is it taken away."

The chapter ends with freedom and transformation. "Where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom. And we all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another. For this comes from the Lord who is the Spirit." We become what we behold. By looking at Christ in Scripture, we are changed.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 34:29-35 tells of Moses' veil. Jeremiah 31:31-34 and Ezekiel 36:26-27 promise the new covenant. Romans 8:1-4 and 15:4 are related. Ephesians 1:13-14 speaks of the seal and guarantee. Isaiah 51:12 speaks of comfort. Philippians 3:3-11 compares old and new. Hebrews 8 to 10 explain the superiority of the new covenant. Colossians 1:15 calls Christ the image of God. Romans 12:2 speaks of transformation.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a suffering you have been through. Whom can you now comfort with the comfort you received?

Spend ten minutes looking at Christ in a Gospel passage and ask the Spirit to transform you.

Thank God that all his promises are Yes in Christ. Say "Amen" to a specific promise.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank the Father of mercies for comforting you.
- Ask him to help you comfort someone else with the comfort you received.
- Thank him for the ministry of the new covenant.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 112

“My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness.”

2 CORINTHIANS 12:9

DAY 779 · WEEK 112

2 Corinthians 5:1-10; Philippians 1:21-24; Luke 23:39-43

Death and the Intermediate State

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Corinthians 5:1-10, Philippians 1:21-24, and Luke 23:39-43. Today is a doctrinal pause on death and the intermediate state, the time between a believer's death and the resurrection. Notice what Paul expects and what Jesus promises.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday and the day before, we studied the resurrection of the dead at the end of the age. But what happens to believers who die before Christ returns? Paul was facing possible death in Asia, and in Philippians he wrote from prison, aware that he might be executed. Their words, along with Jesus' promise to the thief on the cross, tell us what the New Testament says about the time between death and resurrection.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For we know that if the tent that is our earthly home is destroyed, we have a building from God, a house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens" (2 Corinthians 5:1).
2. "For we walk by faith, not by sight" (2 Corinthians 5:7).
3. "We would rather be away from the body and at home with the Lord" (2 Corinthians 5:8).
4. "For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ" (2 Corinthians 5:10).
5. "For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain" (Philippians 1:21).
6. "My desire is to depart and be with Christ, for that is far better" (Philippians 1:23).

7. “Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom” (Luke 23:42).
8. “Truly, I say to you, today you will be with me in Paradise” (Luke 23:43).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The intermediate state is the condition of a person between death and the resurrection of the body. Scripture teaches that when a believer dies, the person is immediately with Christ, in conscious fellowship and joy, although without a resurrection body. Paul says to be “away from the body” is to be “at home with the Lord.” He says that departing is “far better” than staying. Jesus told the penitent thief, “Today you will be with me in Paradise.” This is the common evangelical understanding, and it is a great comfort.

This state is not the final one. Paul pictures it as being “unclothed” (2 Corinthians 5:3-4), awaiting the “clothing” of the resurrection body. The final hope remains the resurrection and the new creation. The intermediate state is a waiting period, but it is a good one, in the presence of Christ.

Several other views exist. Some Christians hold to “soul sleep,” the idea that the dead are unconscious until the resurrection. The language of “sleep” in the New Testament describes how death looks from our side, but passages like Philippians 1 and Luke 23 point to conscious fellowship. The Roman Catholic Church teaches purgatory, a place of purification after death for those who die in grace but not fully cleansed. Protestants reject this because Christ’s work on the cross is sufficient, and Scripture speaks of immediate presence with Christ. Other traditions emphasize that God’s people await the resurrection, stressing the whole person.

For unbelievers, the New Testament speaks of a state of waiting for judgment, with the final judgment to come (Luke 16:19-31; Hebrews 9:27). All will appear before the judgment seat of Christ. For believers, this is not a judgment about our standing, which is secure in Christ, but about our works, for reward. The thought of that day motivates faithful service.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins 2 Corinthians 5 with a contrast between the earthly tent and the eternal building. A tent is temporary; our bodies are like tents, vulnerable and short-lived. If the tent is destroyed, we have a building from God, “a house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens.” In the meantime, “we groan, longing to put on our heavenly dwelling.” He does not want to be unclothed but further clothed, “so that what is mortal may be swallowed up by life.” God has prepared us for this and given us the Spirit as a guarantee.

“So we are always of good courage. We know that while we are at home in the body we are away from the Lord, for we walk by faith, not by sight. Yes, we are of good courage, and we would rather be away from the body and at home with the Lord.” To be “at home with the Lord” is the heart of the intermediate state. Whether at home or away, our aim is to please him, “for we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, so that each one may receive what is due for what he has done in the body, whether good or evil.” For the believer, this is a day for evaluation and reward, not condemnation (Romans 8:1).

In Philippians 1, Paul is in prison, uncertain whether he will live or die. He writes, “For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain.” He is hard-pressed between the two: “My desire is to depart and be with Christ, for that is far better. But to remain in the flesh is more necessary on your account.” Notice his confidence: death does not end fellowship with Christ; it increases it. The word “depart” was used of a ship loosing its moorings or a tent being taken down.

In Luke 23, one of the criminals crucified with Jesus rebukes the other, acknowledges his own guilt, and says, “Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom.” He had no time for baptism, good works, or a long spiritual track record. Jesus answers with a promise: “Truly, I say to you, today you will be with me in Paradise.” Salvation by grace through faith, and immediate presence with Christ, in one scene. “Today.” The thief received what Paul described.

Death is still an enemy, and Christians grieve. But it has lost its sting, and it is the doorway to being with Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 23:4 speaks of walking through the valley of the shadow of death. Psalm 116:15 says the death of his saints is precious. Ecclesiastes 12:7 speaks of the spirit returning to God. Luke 16:19-31 tells of the rich man and Lazarus. John 14:1-3 promises a place with him. Acts 7:59 records Stephen’s prayer, “Lord Jesus, receive my spirit.” Hebrews 12:22-24 mentions the spirits of the righteous made perfect. Revelation 6:9-11 shows souls under the altar. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 comforts the grieving. Romans 14:7-9 says whether we live or die, we are the Lord’s.

STEP 6

Application

Write down what you believe about what happens when a Christian dies. Compare it to these passages.

Pray for someone who is facing death or grief. Share Philippians 1:21 with them.

Ask what it would mean to say, “To me to live is Christ,” in your daily work.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you think about death today.
- Thank Jesus that to live is Christ and to die is gain.
- Thank him that to be away from the body is to be at home with him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 112

“My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness.”

2 CORINTHIANS 12:9

DAY 780 · WEEK 112

2 Corinthians 4:1-5:21

Treasure in jars of clay; ambassadors for Christ

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 39 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Corinthians 4:1-5:21. This is among Paul's most moving writing. Notice the treasure in jars of clay, the contrast between the outer and inner self, the new creation, and the ministry of reconciliation.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has been defending his ministry against critics who find him weak. In these chapters he explains that weakness is how the power of God is shown. He is not discouraged by suffering because he sees the unseen and eternal. And he describes his message as the word of reconciliation, the center of the gospel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For what we proclaim is not ourselves, but Jesus Christ as Lord, with ourselves as your servants for Jesus" sake' (4:5).
2. "For God, who said, Let light shine out of darkness, has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ" (4:6).
3. "But we have this treasure in jars of clay, to show that the surpassing power belongs to God and not to us" (4:7).
4. "So we do not lose heart. Though our outer self is wasting away, our inner self is being renewed day by day" (4:16).
5. "For this light momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison" (4:17).

6. “Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away; behold, the new has come” (5:17).
7. “Therefore, we are ambassadors for Christ, God making his appeal through us” (5:20).
8. “For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God” (5:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul says that because they have received mercy, they do not lose heart. They have renounced disgraceful, underhanded ways; they do not use cunning or tamper with God’s word. They commend themselves by the open statement of the truth. If the gospel is veiled, it is veiled to those who are perishing, “in their case the god of this world has blinded the minds of the unbelievers, to keep them from seeing the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God.” Preachers do not proclaim themselves but “Jesus Christ as Lord, with ourselves as your servants for Jesus” sake.’ And the great reason for hope: “For God, who said, Let light shine out of darkness, has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ.” Conversion is a new creation, like the first day of creation.

Then the paradox: “But we have this treasure in jars of clay, to show that the surpassing power belongs to God and not to us.” The treasure is the gospel; the jars of clay are cheap, fragile, ordinary containers. We are weak so that God’s power is clear. He lists the pressures: “afflicted in every way, but not crushed; perplexed, but not driven to despair; persecuted, but not forsaken; struck down, but not destroyed.” We always carry in the body the death of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be manifested in our bodies. “So death is at work in us, but life in you.”

Because of faith in the God who raises the dead, “we do not lose heart.” The outer self wastes away; the inner self is renewed day by day. “For this light momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison, as we look not to the things that are seen but to the things that are unseen. For the things that are seen are transient, but the things that are unseen are eternal.” Paul does not minimize suffering; elsewhere he lists beatings, shipwrecks, and sleeplessness. He weighs it against eternal glory.

Chapter 5 continues with the longing for the resurrection body (see the previous pause) and then turns to Christ’s love. “For the love of Christ controls us, because we have concluded this: that one has died for all, therefore all have died; and he died for all, that those who live might no longer live for themselves but for him who for their sake died and was raised.” This changes how we see everyone: “From now on, therefore, we regard no one according to the flesh.” And then: “Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed

away; behold, the new has come." All this is from God, who through Christ reconciled us to himself and gave us the ministry of reconciliation. "In Christ God was reconciling the world to himself, not counting their trespasses against them, and entrusting to us the message of reconciliation." So we are ambassadors for Christ. "We implore you on behalf of Christ, be reconciled to God." The chapter ends with the heart of the gospel: "For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God." The great exchange: our sin was counted to Christ, and his righteousness is counted to us.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:3 is the creation of light. Isaiah 9:2 and 60:1-3 speak of light shining in darkness. Colossians 1:15-20 describes Christ as the image of God and the reconciler. Romans 5:10-11 speaks of reconciliation. Ephesians 2:11-22 speaks of reconciliation between Jew and Gentile and with God. Isaiah 53:4-6, 10-12 and Galatians 3:13 teach substitution. Isaiah 43:19 speaks of a new thing. Revelation 21:5 says "Behold, I am making all things new." Isaiah 49:8 is quoted in 2 Corinthians 6:2. Matthew 5:11-12 and Romans 8:18 speak of suffering and glory.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you feel like a cracked jar of clay. Offer that weakness to God as a display of his power.

Practice looking at the unseen. Spend time today remembering what is eternal.

Be an ambassador: speak to someone about being reconciled to God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for shining in your heart the light of the knowledge of his glory.
- Tell him what makes you feel like a jar of clay.
- Ask him to make you a faithful ambassador.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 112

“My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness.”

2 CORINTHIANS 12:9

DAY 781 · WEEK 112

2 Corinthians 6:1-9:15

Holiness; Paul's hardships; generous giving

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 89 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Corinthians 6:1-9:15. These four chapters hold several themes: the day of salvation, holiness and separation, godly grief and repentance, and generous giving. Read the appeal for the collection in chapters 8 and 9 slowly, noticing its motive.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul continues his defense of the ministry and moves to appeals. He urges the Corinthians not to receive God's grace in vain, to pursue holiness, and to complete their promised gift for the poor believers in Jerusalem. Titus has brought news that the church repented after Paul's painful letter, and Paul rejoices. The collection in chapters 8 and 9 is the longest discussion of Christian giving in the New Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, now is the favorable time; behold, now is the day of salvation" (6:2).
2. "As sorrowful, yet always rejoicing; as poor, yet making many rich; as having nothing, and yet possessing everything" (6:10).
3. "For godly grief produces a repentance that leads to salvation without regret, whereas worldly grief produces death" (7:10).
4. "For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor, so that you by his poverty might become rich" (8:9).
5. "For if the readiness is there, it is acceptable according to what a person has, not according to what he does not have" (8:12).

6. “Whoever sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and whoever sows bountifully will also reap bountifully” (9:6).

7. “Each one must give as he has decided in his heart, not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver” (9:7).

8. “Thanks be to God for his inexpressible gift!” (9:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul urges the Corinthians, as God’s fellow workers, not to receive the grace of God in vain. Quoting Isaiah 49:8, he says, “Behold, now is the favorable time; behold, now is the day of salvation.” He then describes his own ministry through a list of hardships and virtues: afflictions, hardships, calamities, beatings, imprisonments, riots, labors, sleepless nights, hunger; by purity, knowledge, patience, kindness, the Holy Spirit, genuine love, truthful speech, and the power of God. “As sorrowful, yet always rejoicing; as poor, yet making many rich; as having nothing, and yet possessing everything.” The Christian life is full of paradox.

Then comes a call to holiness: “Do not be unequally yoked with unbelievers. For what partnership has righteousness with lawlessness? Or what fellowship has light with darkness?” This is not a call to withdraw from the world but to avoid being joined to what contradicts our devotion to Christ. The reason: “For we are the temple of the living God.” God promises, “I will make my dwelling among them and walk among them… I will be a father to you, and you shall be sons and daughters to me.” The chapter ends with the call to cleanse ourselves from every defilement of body and spirit, bringing holiness to completion in the fear of God.

In chapter 7, Paul rejoices that the church responded to his painful letter. “For godly grief produces a repentance that leads to salvation without regret, whereas worldly grief produces death.” Worldly grief is sorrow at being caught; godly grief is sorrow at sinning against God. Titus was refreshed by their response, and Paul’s joy is complete.

Chapters 8 and 9 speak of the collection. The Macedonian churches, in a severe test of affliction, with abundance of joy and extreme poverty, overflowed in a wealth of generosity. They gave beyond their means, begging earnestly for the favor of taking part. Notice the order: “They gave themselves first to the Lord and then by the will of God to us.” Giving flows from devotion. Then the ground of all giving: “For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor, so that you by his poverty might become rich.” The incarnation is the model of generosity. Paul does not command but tests the sincerity of their love. Principles: give willingly, according to what you have, so that there may be fairness. Transparency and accountability are important: Titus and others will handle the funds so that no one can criticize.

Chapter 9 gives encouragement. “Whoever sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and whoever sows bountifully will also reap bountifully.” “Each one must give as he has decided in his heart, not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver.” This does not promise material wealth in return; the harvest is righteousness and thanksgiving. “God is able to make all grace abound to you, so that having all sufficiency in all things at all times, you may abound in every good work.” Quoting Psalm 112:9, “He has distributed freely, he has given to the poor; his righteousness endures forever.” The result of generosity is thanksgiving to God. The chapter ends with praise: “Thanks be to God for his inexpressible gift!” The ultimate gift is Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 49:8 is quoted in 6:2. Leviticus 26:11-12 and Ezekiel 37:27 stand behind 6:16. Psalm 112:9 is quoted in 9:9. Acts 11:27-30 and Romans 15:25-27 describe the collection. Philippians 2:5-8 shows Christ’s self-emptying. Philippians 4:10-20 speaks of the Philippians’ gift. Luke 21:1-4 records the widow’s offering. Proverbs 11:24-25 and 22:9 speak of generosity. Matthew 6:19-21 says where your treasure is, there your heart will be. Psalm 51:17 and Luke 18:13 show true repentance.

STEP 6

Application

Choose an amount to give that stretches you. Do it cheerfully, not by compulsion.

Distinguish worldly grief from godly grief in your own heart. Are you sorry for the sin, or for the consequences?

Meditate on 8:9 and remember the cost of Christ’s generosity to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for becoming poor so that you might become rich.
- Ask him to make you cheerful in giving.
- Tell him how you want to give this week.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 112

“My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness.”

2 CORINTHIANS 12:9

DAY 782 · WEEK 112

2 Corinthians 10:1-13:14

Paul's authority; boasting in weakness

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Reading · 85 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Corinthians 10:1-13:14. Paul's tone shifts here, as he defends his apostleship against false teachers. Read with an ear for his irony and his pain. Pay special attention to the thorn in the flesh and the answer he received in 12:7-10.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Some in Corinth, influenced by self-styled "super-apostles," dismissed Paul as unimpressive in person and contemptible in speech. They boasted of credentials, visions, and eloquence. Paul is reluctant to boast, but to defend the gospel he does a kind of "fool's boasting" in which he boasts of his weaknesses. This section reverses worldly values and gives one of the Bible's most important teachings on God's strength in weakness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For the weapons of our warfare are not of the flesh but have divine power to destroy strongholds" (10:4).
2. "Let the one who boasts, boast in the Lord" (10:17).
3. "But I am afraid that as the serpent deceived Eve by his cunning, your thoughts will be led astray from a sincere and pure devotion to Christ" (11:3).
4. "If I must boast, I will boast of the things that show my weakness" (11:30).
5. "My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness" (12:9).
6. "For the sake of Christ, then, I am content with weaknesses, insults, hardships, persecutions, and calamities. For when I am weak, then I am strong" (12:10).
7. "Examine yourselves, to see whether you are in the faith. Test yourselves" (13:5).

8 “The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and the love of God and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all” (13:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins by appealing “by the meekness and gentleness of Christ.” He is accused of being bold when away and timid when present. He warns that when he comes, he may have to be bold. “For though we walk in the flesh, we are not waging war according to the flesh. For the weapons of our warfare are not of the flesh but have divine power to destroy strongholds. We destroy arguments and every lofty opinion raised against the knowledge of God, and take every thought captive to obey Christ.” The spiritual battle is fought with truth, prayer, and the word, not with manipulation or force. He refuses to compare himself with those who commend themselves. “Let the one who boasts, boast in the Lord. For it is not the one who commends himself who is approved, but the one whom the Lord commends.”

In chapter 11, Paul’s jealousy for the church leads him to a painful comparison. He has betrothed them to one husband, to present them as a pure virgin to Christ. “But I am afraid that as the serpent deceived Eve by his cunning, your thoughts will be led astray from a sincere and pure devotion to Christ.” The false teachers preach another Jesus, a different spirit, a different gospel. Paul calls them “false apostles, deceitful workmen, disguising themselves as apostles of Christ. And no wonder, for even Satan disguises himself as an angel of light.” Their credentials are impressive, but Paul tallies his own: far more labors, far more imprisonments, with countless beatings, often near death. Five times he received thirty-nine lashes; three times beaten with rods; once stoned; three times shipwrecked; a night and a day adrift at sea; in danger from rivers, robbers, his own people, Gentiles, the city, the wilderness, false brothers; in toil and hardship, sleepless nights, hunger, cold. “And, apart from other things, there is the daily pressure on me of my anxiety for all the churches.” Then: “If I must boast, I will boast of the things that show my weakness,” and he tells of being lowered in a basket through a window in the wall at Damascus.

In chapter 12, he speaks of a vision, “a man in Christ” caught up to the third heaven, hearing things that cannot be told. He refrains from boasting of this. “So to keep me from becoming conceited because of the surpassing greatness of the revelations, a thorn was given me in the flesh, a messenger of Satan to harass me.” We do not know what the thorn was: an illness, a person, a temptation. Three times he pleaded with the Lord to remove it. “But he said to me, My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness. Therefore I will boast all the more gladly of my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest upon me. For the sake of Christ, then, I am content with weaknesses, insults, hardships, persecutions, and calamities. For when I am weak, then I am strong.” God’s answer was not removal but sufficiency. This verse has comforted countless suffering believers.

Paul closes with warnings and tenderness. He fears he will find quarreling, jealousy, and unrepentance. “Examine yourselves, to see whether you are in the faith. Test yourselves. Or do you not realize this about yourselves, that Jesus Christ is in you?” The aim is restoration, not demolition. “Aim for restoration, comfort one another, agree with one another, live in peace; and the God of love and peace will be with you.” The letter ends with the benediction: “The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and the love of God and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all.” It is one of the clearest Trinitarian blessings in the New Testament.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 9:23-24 is the source of 10:17. Genesis 3 describes the serpent’s deceit. Galatians 1:6-9 also warns of false gospels. Ephesians 6:10-18 describes spiritual warfare. Acts 9:23-25 and 14:19 tell of the basket and the stoning. Job 1 to 2 shows Satan allowed to afflict. Isaiah 40:28-31 promises strength to the weary. Philippians 4:13 says I can do all things through him who strengthens me. Hebrews 4:15-16 offers grace to help in time of need. Romans 8:35-39 and 1 Peter 5:10 speak of suffering and grace.

STEP 6

Application

Name your “thorn.” Bring it to the Lord as Paul did. Listen for his answer.

Read 12:9 aloud and apply it to a current weakness.

Examine yourself as 13:5 says. Is Christ in you? Do you have the marks of faith?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring God your “thorn,” and tell him what it is.
- Thank him that his grace is sufficient and his power is perfected in weakness.
- Ask him to teach you to boast in weakness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 112

“My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness.”

2 CORINTHIANS 12:9

DAY 783 · WEEK 112

Review and Reflection

Unit 21 review, Law, Gospel & Church Life, Galatians, Corinthians

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me."
>
> GALATIANS 2:20

REST

Meditation

Paul wrote these words in the middle of an argument about justification, but they are as personal as anything in his letters. They are the unit's key.

"I have been crucified with Christ." Paul speaks of a past event with present effect. When Christ died, those who are in him died with him. The old self, the power of sin, and the curse of the law all came to an end at the cross.

"It is no longer I who live." The self-centered life, the one that lives for its own glory, has been put to death. This is not the loss of personality but of the old master.

"But Christ who lives in me." The risen Christ now lives in the believer by his Spirit. He is not just a teacher to be imitated or a debt-payer to be thanked, but the life within us.

The rest of the verse, which you should read, says: "And the life I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me." We live by trusting him, and the basis is his love and his sacrifice.

This verse answers legalism, which says do more. It answers license, which says do what you want. The answer is union: Christ's death is mine and Christ's life is mine.

When you feel the pull of self-reliance or of sin, say this verse. You are not alone, and you are not what you were.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

You have read Galatians, 1 Corinthians, and 2 Corinthians, three letters that show the gospel at work in churches. In Galatians, Paul defended the gospel against those who added the law to faith: there is no other gospel, a person is justified by faith in Christ and not by works of the law, Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us, and in Christ we are adopted as sons and heirs. We walk by the Spirit, bear his fruit, and boast only in the cross. In 1 Corinthians, you saw a messy, gifted church corrected by the cross: the word of the cross is the power of God, ministers are servants and stewards, the church is God's temple, and Christians use their freedom in love. You studied the Lord's Supper as the meal that proclaims the Lord's death until he comes, spiritual gifts as given by one Spirit for the common good of one body, and love as the more excellent way. Chapter 15 gave the gospel of first importance and the hope of the resurrection of Christ and of the dead. In 2 Corinthians, you saw comfort in affliction, the new covenant ministry of the Spirit, the treasure in jars of clay, the new creation, the ministry of reconciliation, the grace of giving, and the sufficiency of grace in weakness. Doctrinal pauses covered adoption, the Lord's Supper, spiritual gifts, the resurrection of Christ, the resurrection of the dead, and death and the intermediate state. Psalms 33, 62, 111, 112, and 133 sang of God's word, rest in God alone, remembering his works, generosity, and unity.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What is the "different gospel" Paul is writing against in Galatians?

Read Galatians 1:6-9 and 2:15-21. What was added to faith in Christ, and why does Paul say that adding anything destroys the gospel? Where might a version of this temptation appear today?

What does "justification by faith" mean practically?

Consider Galatians 2:16, 3:1-14, and 5:1-6. How does it change your view of yourself, your failures, your obedience, and other people when you rest on Christ's finished work instead of your own performance?

Why does Paul say "I decided to know nothing among you except Jesus Christ and him crucified"?

Look at 1 Corinthians 1:18-2:5. What was wrong with the Corinthians' approach to wisdom and leaders? Why is the cross both foolish to the world and the power of God?

What does the resurrection of 1 Corinthians 15 have to do with everyday Christian living?

Read 1 Corinthians 15:12-20 and 15:50-58. If Christ is raised, what follows for how we face death, suffering, our bodies, and our work for the Lord?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the gospel in Galatians and Corinthians.

Tell him where you have seen law and gospel, grace and church life, together.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

DAY 784 · WEEK 112

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 21 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Corinthians 12:9 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness."

2 CORINTHIANS 12:9

REST

Meditation

These are the words of the Lord Jesus to Paul, spoken after he pleaded three times for relief from his thorn.

"My grace is sufficient for you." The Lord does not say, "I will remove it," but "My grace is enough." Grace here means God's favor and strength given to us in Christ. There is no situation in which it runs out. Paul needed daily grace, and so do we.

"For my power is made perfect in weakness." Weakness is not an obstacle to God's work but an opportunity for it. When we are strong in ourselves, we credit ourselves; when we are weak, the power of Christ is clearly seen. Paul went on to say, "I will boast all the more gladly of my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest upon me."

This verse reverses the world's logic. The world says to hide weakness and project strength. The gospel says to bring weakness to Christ. The cross itself is the great display of power in weakness.

When you are tired, limited, struggling with a thorn, or aware of your inadequacy, say this verse. Christ is not disappointed by your weakness; he is glorified in it. His grace is enough for today.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the unit with 2 Corinthians. In chapters 1 to 3, Paul blessed God as the Father of mercies and God of all comfort, taught that all the promises of God find their Yes in Christ, and described the new covenant ministry of the Spirit that transforms us from one degree of glory to another. A doctrinal pause on death and the intermediate state showed that to be absent from the body is to be at home with the Lord. Chapters 4 and 5 spoke of the treasure in jars of clay, the inner self renewed day by day, the new creation, the ministry of reconciliation, and the great exchange in which Christ was made sin so that we might become the righteousness of God. Chapters 6 to 9 called us to holiness, godly grief, and cheerful generosity, grounded in Christ who became poor for our sake. Chapters 10 to 13 closed with Paul's boasting in weakness, the thorn in the flesh, and the promise that Christ's grace is sufficient. The unit review on Day 783 drew the three letters together around Galatians 2:20.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul's thorn was not removed, but he received grace. What weakness, limitation, or hardship in your life might God be using to display his power? How might you boast in it?

Second Corinthians 5:21 says Christ was made sin for us so that we might become the righteousness of God. What does it mean to you that your sin was counted to him and his righteousness to you?

Paul says we are ambassadors for Christ, entrusted with the message of reconciliation. Who in your life needs to hear it from you? What is one step you can take this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that his grace is sufficient.

Thank him that his power is made perfect in weakness.

Rest in him.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 22 · DAYS 785-819

In Christ: Prison and Pastoral Epistles

Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, Thessalonians, Pastoral Epistles, Philemon

The church as the new humanity. Joy, hope, Christ's supremacy, and sound doctrine.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation."

COLOSSIANS 1:15-16

The ascended Christ (68, 110) and trust under pressure (27, 138, 139).

UNIT 22

In this unit

WEEK 113

785	Ephesians 1:1-23	*Reading*
786	Ephesians 1:3-14; Romans 9:1-24	*Doctrine*
787	Matthew 16:13-20; Ephesians 2:11-22; 1 Peter 2:4-10	*Doctrine*
788	Ephesians 2:1-3:21	*Reading*
789	Ephesians 4:1-32	*Reading*
790	Ephesians 5:1-6:24	*Reading*
791	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 114

792	Psalm 68:1-20	*Psalm*
793	Psalm 110:1-7	*Psalm*
794	Philippians 1:1-2:30	*Reading*
795	Philippians 2:5-11; Hebrews 2:14-18	*Doctrine*
796	Philippians 3:1-4:23	*Reading*
797	Colossians 1:1-2:5	*Reading*
798	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 115

799	Colossians 2:6-3:17	*Reading*
800	Colossians 3:18-4:18	*Reading*
801	1 Corinthians 7:17-24; Colossians 3:22-4:1	*Doctrine*
802	1 Thessalonians 1:1-3:13	*Reading*
803	1 Thessalonians 4:13-18; Matthew 24:30-31; Revelation 1:7	*Doctrine*
804	1 Thessalonians 4:1-5:28	*Reading*
805	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 116

806	Psalm 27	*Psalm*

807	Psalm 138	*Psalm*
808	Psalm 139:13-24	*Psalm*
809	2 Thessalonians 1:1-3:18	*Reading*
810	1 Timothy 1:1-3:16	*Reading*
811	1 Timothy 3:1-13; Titus 1:5-9; Acts 6:1-6	*Doctrine*
812	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 117

813	1 Timothy 4:1-6:21	*Reading*
814	2 Timothy 1:1-2:26	*Reading*
815	2 Timothy 3:1-4:22	*Reading*
816	Titus 1:1-3:15	*Reading*
817	Philemon 1:1-25	*Reading*
818	Review and Reflection	*Review*
819	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 785 · WEEK 113

Ephesians 1:1-23

Every spiritual blessing in Christ

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ephesians 1:1-23. The first fourteen verses are one long sentence in Greek, a single burst of praise. Read it aloud if you can, and notice how many times Paul says “in Christ” or “in him.” Then read the prayer in verses 15-23.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul wrote Ephesians from prison in Rome, around AD 60 to 62, probably as a circular letter for the churches around Ephesus. Together with Philippians, Colossians, and Philemon, it is one of the Prison Epistles. Ephesians has no urgent problem to correct. It is a sustained celebration of what God has done in Christ and what the church is. The first three chapters tell what God has done; the last three tell how to live in light of it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us in Christ with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places” (1:3).
2. “Even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before him” (1:4).
3. “He predestined us for adoption as sons through Jesus Christ” (1:5).
4. “In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses, according to the riches of his grace” (1:7).
5. “A plan for the fullness of time, to unite all things in him, things in heaven and things on earth” (1:10).

6. “In him you also, when you heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation, and believed in him, were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit” (1:13).

7. “Having the eyes of your hearts enlightened, that you may know what is the hope to which he has called you” (1:18).

8. “He put all things under his feet and gave him as head over all things to the church, which is his body” (1:22-23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening is a hymn of praise, not an argument. Paul blesses God because God has blessed us “with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places.” Every blessing is “in Christ.” The rest of the sentence unfolds the blessings in Trinitarian order. The Father chose us “before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless,” and predestined us for adoption “to the praise of his glorious grace.” The Son redeemed us: “In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses.” The Spirit sealed us: when we believed, we “were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit, who is the guarantee of our inheritance until we acquire possession of it.” Three times the refrain returns: to the praise of his glory.

Notice the scope. God’s plan reaches back before creation and forward to “the fullness of time, to unite all things in him, things in heaven and things on earth.” The mystery of his will is that all of history is heading toward one goal: the summing up of everything under Christ. Believers are given an inheritance, obtained “in him,” having been predestined according to the purpose of the God who works all things according to the counsel of his will. We were not an afterthought. We are part of a plan.

Paul then prays for the readers. He gives thanks for their faith and love, and asks that God give them “the Spirit of wisdom and of revelation in the knowledge of him,” so that the eyes of their hearts may be enlightened. He prays for three things: that they know the hope of his calling, the riches of the glory of his inheritance in the saints, and the immeasurable greatness of his power toward us who believe. The measure of that power is the resurrection and exaltation of Christ: God raised him from the dead and seated him at his right hand in the heavenly places, far above all rule and authority and power and dominion, and above every name that is named. “And he put all things under his feet and gave him as head over all things to the church, which is his body, the fullness of him who fills all in all.”

The church is not an afterthought either. Christ rules the universe for the sake of the church. The same power that raised Jesus is at work in believers. When we feel weak, we are to remember that this is the power on our side.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:28-39 and 2 Timothy 1:9 speak of God's purpose before the ages. Colossians 1:15-20 and Philippians 2:9-11 speak of Christ's supremacy. 1 Peter 1:3-5 praises God for a living hope and an inheritance. Psalm 110:1 and Psalm 8:6 stand behind 1:20-22. John 17:24 speaks of the Father's love before the foundation of the world. 2 Corinthians 1:21-22 speaks of the seal and guarantee. Revelation 5:9-14 shows the Lamb worshiped. Romans 11:33-36 is a similar doxology.

STEP 6

Application

Read verses 3 to 14 aloud as a prayer, slowly. Underline each blessing.

Pray for yourself the prayer of verses 17 to 19: that the eyes of your heart would be enlightened.

When you feel weak, remember that the power that raised Christ is at work in you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bless God for blessing you in Christ with every spiritual blessing.
- Thank him for choosing you, adopting you, and sealing you.
- Ask him to open the eyes of your heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 113

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

DAY 786 · WEEK 113

Ephesians 1:3-14; Romans 9:1-24

Election and Predestination

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ephesians 1:3-14 and Romans 9:1-24. Today is a doctrinal pause on election and predestination. Read slowly and with humility. Notice the repeated phrase “in him” in Ephesians and the emphasis on God’s mercy in Romans.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Few doctrines have been as debated as election, and few are as comforting when understood. The word means choosing. Ephesians 1 speaks of God choosing us in Christ before the foundation of the world. Romans 9 stresses that God’s purpose of election works by his mercy, not by human merit or descent. The doctrine is not meant to start arguments but to produce worship, humility, and security. Notice that Ephesians 1 is written in a hymn of praise.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before him” (Ephesians 1:4).
2. “He predestined us for adoption as sons through Jesus Christ, according to the purpose of his will” (Ephesians 1:5).
3. “To the praise of his glorious grace, with which he has blessed us in the Beloved” (Ephesians 1:6).
4. “In him we have obtained an inheritance, having been predestined according to the purpose of him who works all things according to the counsel of his will” (Ephesians 1:11).

5. “In order that God’s purpose of election might continue, not because of works but because of him who calls” (Romans 9:11).
6. “For he says to Moses, I will have mercy on whom I have mercy, and I will have compassion on whom I have compassion” (Romans 9:15).
7. “So then it depends not on human will or exertion, but on God, who has mercy” (Romans 9:16).
8. “In order to make known the riches of his glory for vessels of mercy, which he has prepared beforehand for glory” (Romans 9:23).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Election is God’s choice, before creation and from his own mercy, of a people to be saved in Christ. Predestination is closely related and speaks of God determining beforehand the destiny of those he has chosen: adoption, holiness, and glory. The Bible uses these words, so Christians must take them seriously. They are not ideas of a particular school but of Scripture.

The central point is clear in every tradition: salvation is God’s gift, not human achievement. The Father chose us “in him,” in Christ. We are not chosen because of foreseen goodness. We were chosen “that we should be holy and blameless,” not because we were. The purpose is the praise of his glorious grace. The result is humility and security: God began the work, and he will finish it (Philippians 1:6; Romans 8:29-30).

Christians have understood the details differently. In the Reformed (Calvinist) tradition, God unconditionally chose particular individuals for salvation before the foundation of the world, and he effectually calls them so that they certainly believe. In the Arminian tradition, God elects on the basis of his foreknowledge of who would respond in faith, or elects the church as a corporate body in Christ and individuals as they join it by faith. Other views stress corporate election: Christ is the Chosen One, and those who are in him share his election. Roman Catholic and Orthodox traditions have their own formulations. These debates have been serious and will not be settled here.

Some guidelines help us read faithfully. Hold the mystery: God is sovereign, and human beings are genuinely responsible. Scripture teaches both, and we are not asked to fully reconcile them. Remember the purpose: Paul teaches election to comfort and to elicit praise, not to discourage evangelism. The same Paul who wrote Romans 9 wrote Romans 10 about the necessity of preaching. And never use election as an excuse for pride or fatalism. The right response is worship.

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Ephesians 1, election is first of all about Christ. We were chosen "in him." Jesus is the chosen one, and we share in his election by union with him. The purpose of election is holiness and adoption. It is not a doctrine of exclusion but of grace: "In love he predestined us for adoption." Everything is done "according to the purpose of his will," "to the praise of his glorious grace."

Romans 9 focuses on the question of Israel: why have so many of God's people not believed? Paul's answer begins with a reminder: "Not all who are descended from Israel belong to Israel." The promise always went through God's choice: Isaac, not Ishmael; Jacob, not Esau. "Though they were not yet born and had done nothing either good or bad, in order that God's purpose of election might continue, not because of works but because of him who calls." Paul anticipates the objection: is God unjust? "By no means! For he says to Moses, I will have mercy on whom I have mercy." Salvation "depends not on human will or exertion, but on God, who has mercy." No one deserves mercy; if God gives it to some, no one is wronged. The potter has the right over the clay. And Paul adds that God endures with much patience vessels of wrath prepared for destruction, in order to make known the riches of his glory for vessels of mercy, "whom he has prepared beforehand for glory, even us whom he has called, not from the Jews only but also from the Gentiles."

If you are a Christian, the doctrine means that your salvation does not ultimately rest on your grip on God but on his grip on you. If you are not sure whether you are chosen, the answer is found in the gospel call: come to Christ. "Whoever believes in him will not be put to shame." No one who comes to him is cast out (John 6:37).

STEP 5

Connection

John 6:37-44 and 15:16 speak of the Father giving and drawing. Acts 13:48 says as many as were appointed to eternal life believed. Romans 8:28-30 gives the golden chain. 2 Thessalonians 2:13 speaks of being chosen as firstfruits. 1 Peter 1:1-2 and 2 Peter 1:10 speak of election. Deuteronomy 7:6-8 gives God's choice of Israel from love. 2 Peter 3:9 and 1 Timothy 2:4 speak of God's desire that all be saved. Revelation 13:8 and 17:8 mention the book of life. Philippians 2:12-13 pairs God's work and ours.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God for choosing you, if you are in Christ. Let it humble you and make you secure.

Pray for someone who does not believe. The doctrine of election should drive us to pray and to share the gospel, not away from it.

When you disagree with another Christian on this doctrine, respond with love, remembering that both of you are seeking to honor God's word.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for choosing you in Christ before the foundation of the world.
- Tell him what you cannot fully understand, and rest in him.
- Ask him to make you humble and holy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 113

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

DAY 787 · WEEK 113

Matthew 16:13-20; Ephesians 2:11-22; 1 Peter 2:4-10

The Nature of the Church

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 16:13-20, Ephesians 2:11-22, and 1 Peter 2:4-10. Today is a doctrinal pause on the nature of the church. Notice the images used: a rock, a household, a temple, a priesthood, and a people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The word “church” translates the Greek ekklesia, which means an assembly or gathering. In the Old Testament, it was used for the assembly of Israel. Jesus used the word only twice in the Gospels (Matthew 16:18 and 18:17), but in the rest of the New Testament it appears over a hundred times. The church is central to God’s plan. It is not a human invention but the people whom God has gathered to himself through Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “You are the Christ, the Son of the living God” (Matthew 16:16).
2. “On this rock I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it” (Matthew 16:18).
3. “But now in Christ Jesus you who once were far off have been brought near by the blood of Christ” (Ephesians 2:13).
4. “For he himself is our peace, who has made us both one” (Ephesians 2:14).
5. “You are no longer strangers and aliens, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God” (Ephesians 2:19).
6. “Christ Jesus himself being the cornerstone” (Ephesians 2:20).

7 “You yourselves like living stones are being built up as a spiritual house, to be a holy priesthood” (1 Peter 2:5).

8 “But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession” (1 Peter 2:9).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The church is the people of God, called out of the world by the gospel and united to Christ by the Spirit. It is described in many ways: the body of Christ, the bride of Christ, the household and family of God, the temple of the Spirit, the flock of the Good Shepherd, the pillar and buttress of truth, and the people of God. Each image teaches something. The body speaks of union and mutual dependence; the bride, of love and purity; the family, of belonging; the temple, of God’s presence; the flock, of care.

We can distinguish the universal church and the local church. The universal church is all those united to Christ by faith in every time and place. The local church is a particular gathering of believers who meet regularly under the word, practice the ordinances, and are accountable to each other. Many theologians distinguish the visible church, which includes everyone who professes faith, from the invisible church, which includes only those who are truly regenerate. The marks of a true church, according to the Reformers, are the faithful preaching of the word and the right administration of the sacraments or ordinances. Many add discipline.

The church is what Israel was called to be, now expanded to include Gentiles. In Ephesians 2, Paul says that Gentiles who were “alienated from the commonwealth of Israel” are now fellow citizens. In 1 Peter 2:9, the titles once given to Israel in Exodus 19:5-6 are given to the church: a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation. This is part of the progressive covenantal reading of Scripture: Christ is the true Israel, and the church, united to him, is the people of God, in continuity with the Old Testament people and yet new.

Christians differ on the meaning of “on this rock” in Matthew 16:18. Roman Catholics hold that the rock is Peter, as the first pope. Many Protestants hold that the rock is Peter’s confession (that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of the living God), or Christ himself, or Peter as representative of the apostles. Christians also differ on church government, which we study on Day 811. All agree that Christ builds his church and that it will not fail.

STEP 4

Interpretation

At Caesarea Philippi, Jesus asks, “Who do you say that I am?” Peter answers, “You are the Christ, the Son of the living God.” Jesus blesses him: flesh and blood did not reveal this, but the Father. “And I tell you, you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it.” The church is built on the apostolic confession of who Jesus is. Whether the “rock” is Peter, his confession, or both, the point is clear: Christ is the builder, and the gates of death will not stop him. Jesus also gives the keys of the kingdom, the authority to declare, through the gospel, who enters.

Ephesians 2:11-22 describes the church as a new humanity. Gentiles were “separated from Christ, alienated from the commonwealth of Israel and strangers to the covenants of promise, having no hope and without God in the world.” But now they have been brought near. Christ “has broken down in his flesh the dividing wall of hostility” between Jew and Gentile, by abolishing the law of commandments expressed in ordinances, “that he might create in himself one new man in place of the two.” Together they have access in one Spirit to the Father. “So then you are no longer strangers and aliens, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God, built on the foundation of the apostles and the prophets, Christ Jesus himself being the cornerstone, in whom the whole structure, being joined together, grows into a holy temple in the Lord.” The church is a building with Christ at its center and a living organism that is growing.

Peter adds that believers are “living stones” built into a spiritual house, a holy priesthood to offer spiritual sacrifices. Christ is the living stone, rejected by men but chosen and precious. For those who believe, he is precious; for those who do not, he is a stone of stumbling. Believers have a purpose: “that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light.” “Once you were not a people, but now you are God’s people; once you had not received mercy, but now you have received mercy.”

The church is the community of the redeemed. It is not optional for the Christian. We were saved into a people.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 19:5-6 is the source of 1 Peter 2:9. Psalm 118:22 and Isaiah 28:16 are quoted in 1 Peter 2:6-8. Hosea 1:9 to 2:23 is echoed in 1 Peter 2:10. Matthew 18:15-20 gives Jesus’ words on the church. Acts 2:42-47 shows the first church. 1 Corinthians 12:12-27 describes the body. Hebrews 10:24-25 urges us not to neglect meeting together. Revelation 21:9-14 pictures the bride and the city. Ephesians 5:25-27 says Christ loved the church and gave himself for her.

STEP 6

Application

If you are not part of a local church, prayerfully find one this week. If you are, thank God for it.

Ask what it would mean to see your fellow members as brothers and sisters, not as an audience.

Think of the church's mission: to proclaim the excellencies of him who called us.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for building his church.

Ask him to show you your place in it.

Pray for your own church.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 113

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

DAY 788 · WEEK 113

Ephesians 2:1-3:21

By grace through faith; the new humanity; the mystery

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ephesians 2:1-3:21. Chapter 2 is the gospel in miniature: dead, made alive, saved by grace, made one. Chapter 3 is about the mystery of the Gentiles' inclusion and ends with a prayer and a doxology. Take time with 2:8-10 and 3:14-21.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In chapter 1, Paul described what God has done in eternity and in Christ. In chapter 2, he describes what happened to us: we were dead, and God made us alive. Then he describes what happened between Jew and Gentile: the wall came down. Chapter 3 explains that this was the long-hidden mystery, and Paul's calling is to proclaim it. The chapter closes with one of Paul's greatest prayers.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And you were dead in the trespasses and sins" (2:1).
2. "But God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ" (2:4-5).
3. "For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast" (2:8-9).
4. "For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them" (2:10).
5. "That he might create in himself one new man in place of the two, so making peace" (2:15).

6. “This mystery is that the Gentiles are fellow heirs, members of the same body, and partakers of the promise in Christ Jesus through the gospel” (3:6).

7. “That you, being rooted and grounded in love, may have strength to comprehend with all the saints what is the breadth and length and height and depth” (3:17-18).

8. “Now to him who is able to do far more abundantly than all that we ask or think, according to the power at work within us, to him be glory in the church and in Christ Jesus throughout all generations, forever and ever” (3:20-21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter begins with the worst news: “You were dead in the trespasses and sins in which you once walked, following the course of this world, following the prince of the power of the air.” Dead is dead. Not sick, not weak, but dead. We were by nature children of wrath, carrying out the desires of the body and the mind. This is a bleak but accurate picture of humanity without Christ.

Then the two most beautiful words in the Bible: “But God.” “But God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ.” The sequence is raising with Christ, seating with Christ. All of it is grace. “For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast.” Faith itself is a gift. Salvation excludes boasting. Yet it is not for idleness: “For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them.” We are not saved by works, but we are saved for works. The word “workmanship” is poiema, from which we get “poem.” We are God’s work of art.

Verses 11 to 22 turn to the Gentiles, who were far off. “But now in Christ Jesus you who once were far off have been brought near by the blood of Christ. For he himself is our peace.” The “dividing wall of hostility” may allude to the barrier in the temple that kept Gentiles out of the inner courts. Christ abolished the hostility and made one new humanity. This is a key text for understanding the relationship between Israel and the church: not replacement, but a new creation in which Jew and Gentile are united in one body under one Head.

In chapter 3, Paul speaks of the mystery: “that the Gentiles are fellow heirs, members of the same body, and partakers of the promise in Christ Jesus through the gospel.” It was not made known in other generations as it has now been revealed. Paul has been given the grace to preach to the Gentiles “the unsearchable riches of Christ” and to make known to the rulers and authorities in the heavenly places the manifold wisdom of God through the church. Even angels learn about God by watching the church.

He bows his knees and prays: that God would strengthen them with power through his Spirit in the inner being, that Christ may dwell in their hearts through faith, that they being rooted and grounded in love may comprehend the breadth and length and height and depth, and know the love of Christ that surpasses knowledge, "that you may be filled with all the fullness of God." It is a prayer for knowing what cannot be fully known. And then the doxology, to the God who can do more than we ask or think.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 3 and Romans 5:12-21 explain our deadness in Adam. Romans 3:21-28 and Titus 3:3-7 teach salvation by grace. Isaiah 57:19 is cited in 2:17. Colossians 1:26-27 also speaks of the mystery. Romans 16:25-27 is a related doxology. Galatians 3:26-29 speaks of union of Jew and Gentile. John 15:5 and Colossians 3:3-4 speak of Christ in us. 1 Peter 1:10-12 says angels long to look into these things. Jude 24-25 is another doxology.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Ephesians 2:8-10. Write it where you will see it.

Ask what "good works" God has prepared for you today, and look for one.

Pray Paul's prayer of 3:16-19 for a friend or for your church.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for making you alive when you were dead in sin.

Thank him that you are saved by grace through faith, a gift.

Ask him to help you walk in the good works he prepared.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 113

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

DAY 789 · WEEK 113

Ephesians 4:1-32

Unity; spiritual gifts; the new self

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ephesians 4:1-32. The letter turns from “what God has done” to “how we then should live.” Read the first sixteen verses on unity and gifts, and the last verses on putting off the old self and putting on the new.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapters 1 to 3 are doctrine; chapters 4 to 6 are practice. The word “therefore” at the start of chapter 4 connects them. The Christian life is a response to what God has done. Paul begins with the church’s unity, then moves to individuals: how to live as a new person. This chapter links with Psalm 68 and Psalm 110, which we read in the coming days.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “I therefore, a prisoner for the Lord, urge you to walk in a manner worthy of the calling to which you have been called” (4:1).
2. “Eager to maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace” (4:3).
3. “One Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God and Father of all, who is over all and through all and in all” (4:5-6).
4. “Rather, speaking the truth in love, we are to grow up in every way into him who is the head, into Christ” (4:15).
5. “To put on the new self, created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness” (4:24).
6. “Let no corrupting talk come out of your mouths, but only such as is good for building up” (4:29).

7. “And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption” (4:30).

8. “Be kind to one another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, as God in Christ forgave you” (4:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul, “a prisoner for the Lord,” urges the church to walk worthy of their calling: “with all humility and gentleness, with patience, bearing with one another in love, eager to maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace.” Notice that unity is something we maintain, not create. The Spirit has already made us one. The basis is the seven “ones”: one body, one Spirit, one hope, one Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God and Father of all. The Trinity is the foundation of church unity.

Unity is not uniformity. “But grace was given to each one of us according to the measure of Christ’s gift.” Paul quotes Psalm 68:18: “When he ascended on high he led a host of captives, and he gave gifts to men.” The ascended Christ gives gifts to his church: apostles, prophets, evangelists, shepherds, and teachers, “to equip the saints for the work of ministry, for building up the body of Christ, until we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to mature manhood, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ.” The goal is Christlikeness, and the means is the ministry of every member. Immaturity is marked by being “tossed to and fro by the waves and carried about by every wind of doctrine.” Maturity is marked by “speaking the truth in love” and growing into Christ.

Verses 17 to 24 describe the change. The Gentiles walk “in the futility of their minds,” darkened in understanding, hardened in heart, callous, given over to sensuality. “But that is not the way you learned Christ.” The imagery is clothing: put off the old self, which is corrupt through deceitful desires, be renewed in the spirit of your minds, and put on the new self, “created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness.” Holiness starts with a change of identity and shows up in daily choices.

Then practical commands, each with a reason. Put away falsehood and speak the truth, for we are members one of another. Be angry and do not sin; do not let the sun go down on your anger. Let the thief no longer steal, but work, so that he may have something to share with the needy. Let no corrupting talk come out of your mouths, only what is good for building up. “And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption.” The Spirit is a person who can be grieved by sin, especially by bitterness and malice. Instead: “Be kind to one another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, as God in Christ forgave you.” The standard of forgiveness is the cross.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 68:18 is quoted in 4:8. Colossians 3:5-17 is a parallel on putting off and putting on. 1 Corinthians 12 and Romans 12 treat the gifts. John 17:20-23 is Jesus' prayer for unity. Zechariah 8:16 stands behind 4:25. Psalm 4:4 is quoted in 4:26. Matthew 6:14-15 and 18:21-35 teach forgiveness. Hebrews 12:15 warns against a root of bitterness. 2 Corinthians 5:17 speaks of the new creation. 1 Thessalonians 5:19 says not to quench the Spirit.

STEP 6

Application

Identify one place where you could maintain unity: a strained relationship at church or home. Take a step.

Examine your words this week. Ask, is this good for building up?

Forgive someone as God in Christ forgave you, if you need to.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you walk worthy of your calling.

Ask him to make you humble, gentle, and patient.

Ask him to help you put off the old self and put on the new.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 113

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

DAY 790 · WEEK 113

Ephesians 5:1-6:24

Walk in love; household codes; the armor of God

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ephesians 5:1-6:24. This long reading continues the practical section: walking in love and light, being filled with the Spirit, relationships in the household, and the armor of God. Read with care, as Paul's teaching on marriage is both beautiful and debated. Read the armor of God as an invitation to stand.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul continues his instructions for the Christian life. He starts with imitating God and walking in love, then describes life in the Spirit, then addresses relationships in the household: wives and husbands, children and parents, slaves and masters. Finally he turns to spiritual warfare. The household instructions were countercultural. Husbands are told to love like Christ; children, wives, and slaves are addressed as moral agents; masters are warned that they have a Master in heaven.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And walk in love, as Christ loved us and gave himself up for us, a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God" (5:2).
2. "And do not get drunk with wine, for that is debauchery, but be filled with the Spirit" (5:18).
3. "Submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ" (5:21).
4. "Husbands, love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her" (5:25).
5. "Finally, be strong in the Lord and in the strength of his might" (6:10).

6. “For we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the cosmic powers over this present darkness” (6:12).
7. “And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God” (6:17).
8. “Praying at all times in the Spirit, with all prayer and supplication” (6:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“Therefore be imitators of God, as beloved children. And walk in love, as Christ loved us and gave himself up for us.” The pattern for the Christian life is God’s own love in Christ. Paul warns against sexual immorality, impurity, covetousness, and obscene talk, which are not fitting among saints. “For at one time you were darkness, but now you are light in the Lord. Walk as children of light.” Light exposes darkness and shows what pleases the Lord.

“Be filled with the Spirit.” This is a command in the present tense, meaning to keep being filled. It is contrasted with drunkenness: instead of being controlled by wine, be controlled by the Spirit. The results are described in participles: speaking to one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing and making melody to the Lord, giving thanks, and submitting to one another. A Spirit-filled life is marked by worship, gratitude, and mutual submission.

Then the household. “Submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ” introduces the passage. “Wives, submit to your own husbands, as to the Lord. For the husband is the head of the wife even as Christ is the head of the church.” The key is the pattern of Christ. Husbands are told, “Love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her, that he might sanctify her.” Headship is defined by sacrificial love. Marriage is a picture of Christ and the church: “This mystery is profound, and I am saying that it refers to Christ and the church.” Christians differ on the application: complementarians understand the passage to describe distinct roles in which husbands lead and wives submit, while egalitarians stress mutual submission in verse 21 and understand headship as source or servant leadership. Both agree that husbands must love sacrificially and that abuse of any kind violates this text.

Children are to obey their parents in the Lord, for it is right, and honor them, the first commandment with a promise. Fathers are not to provoke their children to anger, but to bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord. Slaves are to obey with sincerity, as serving Christ, and masters are to do the same to them, knowing that both have a Master in heaven who shows no partiality. Paul’s teaching undermines the slave system from within.

The letter ends with a call to battle. “Be strong in the Lord and in the strength of his might. Put on the whole armor of God, that you may be able to stand against the schemes of the devil.” The enemy is not human but spiritual. The armor: the belt of truth, the breastplate of righteousness, shoes of the readiness given by the gospel of peace, the shield of faith, the helmet of salvation, the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God. Almost all of it is defensive; the aim is to stand. And all of it is surrounded by prayer: “praying at all times in the Spirit.” Paul asks for prayer for himself, that he would declare the gospel boldly. The letter ends with peace, love, and grace.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 2:24 is quoted in 5:31. Exodus 20:12 is quoted in 6:2-3. Isaiah 11:4-5, 52:7, and 59:17 stand behind the armor. 1 Peter 3:1-7 gives parallel household teaching. Colossians 3:18 to 4:1 is a close parallel. Philemon applies the teaching on masters and slaves. Psalm 119 praises the word. 2 Corinthians 10:3-5 describes spiritual warfare. 1 Peter 5:8-9 warns of the devil. Matthew 4:1-11 shows Jesus using the sword of the Spirit. James 4:7 says resist the devil.

STEP 6

Application

Pray through each piece of the armor this week. Name each as you put it on.

If you are married, ask your spouse how you could love them more like Christ. If you are a parent, look for an area where you can bring up your children in the Lord.

Pray for a missionary or pastor who is boldly declaring the gospel.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you walk in love as Christ loved you.
- Ask him to fill you with his Spirit.
- Ask him to help you put on the whole armor of God.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 113

“For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast.”

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

DAY 791 · WEEK 113

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Ephesians 2:8-9 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

REST

Meditation

These two verses may be the most quoted summary of the gospel of grace.

"For by grace." Grace is God's favor given freely to those who do not deserve it. It is the source of everything.

"You have been saved." The verb is in the perfect tense: it was done in the past with results that continue. You are not hoping to be saved by your effort; you have been saved.

"Through faith." Faith is the means by which we receive what grace offers. It is not a work but an empty hand. It looks to Christ.

"And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God." Everything, including the faith itself, is God's gift. We did not contribute.

“Not a result of works, so that no one may boast.” If salvation depended on us even a little, we could take some credit. As it is, all the glory goes to God.

And verse 10 adds what follows: we are his workmanship, created for good works. We are saved by grace, not by works, but for works.

When pride or despair threatens, say these verses. Both are answered by grace.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the Prison Epistles with Ephesians. In chapter 1, Paul praised God for blessing us in Christ with every spiritual blessing: chosen, adopted, redeemed, and sealed with the Spirit, to the praise of his glorious grace. Two doctrinal pauses considered election and predestination, and the nature of the church as the people of God built on Christ the cornerstone. Ephesians 2 and 3 showed us dead in sin and made alive by grace through faith, Jew and Gentile made one new humanity, and the mystery of Christ revealed. Chapters 4 to 6 turned to life in Christ: unity of the Spirit, gifts for equipping the saints, putting off the old self and putting on the new, walking in love, the household, and the armor of God.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says every spiritual blessing is ours in Christ. Which of the blessings in Ephesians 1:3-14 is hardest for you to believe is true of you? How might you remind yourself of it this week?

Ephesians 2:8-10 says we are saved by grace through faith, for good works. Which is your greater temptation: to rely on your works or to neglect them? How does grace answer both?

Ephesians 4 tells us to maintain the unity of the Spirit. Is there a relationship in your church or family where you need to take the first step? What is it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are saved by grace through faith, a gift.

Rest in what Christ has done.

Ask him to keep you standing.

DAY 792 · WEEK 114

Psalm 68:1-20

God gives gifts to men, the psalm behind Ephesians 4

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 68:1-20. This is one of the most majestic psalms in the Psalter. Paul quotes verse 18 in Ephesians 4:8. Read it as a victory procession of God, and notice what God does for the lonely and the needy.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 68 is a psalm of David, probably composed for the procession of the ark into Jerusalem. It begins with the words Moses spoke when the ark set out in the wilderness (Numbers 10:35). It recalls the exodus, Sinai, the conquest, and God's reign from Zion. In Ephesians 4, Paul takes verse 18, about God ascending on high leading captives, and applies it to Christ's ascension and the gifts he gives his church.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "God shall arise, his enemies shall be scattered; and those who hate him shall flee before him!" (v. 1).
2. "But the righteous shall be glad; they shall exult before God; they shall be jubilant with joy!" (v. 3).
3. "Father of the fatherless and protector of widows is God in his holy habitation" (v. 5).
4. "God settles the solitary in a home" (v. 6).
5. "You ascended on high, leading a host of captives in your train" (v. 18).
6. "And receiving gifts among men, even among the rebellious, that the LORD God may dwell there" (v. 18).
7. "Blessed be the Lord, who daily bears us up; God is our salvation" (v. 19).

8 “Our God is a God of salvation, and to GOD, the Lord, belong deliverances from death” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts with a battle cry: “God shall arise, his enemies shall be scattered.” As smoke is driven away, so he drives them away; as wax melts before fire, so the wicked perish before God. Meanwhile, “the righteous shall be glad; they shall exult before God; they shall be jubilant with joy.” The same God who is terrifying to his enemies is the joy of his people.

Then comes one of the most tender descriptions of God in the Bible: “Father of the fatherless and protector of widows is God in his holy habitation. God settles the solitary in a home; he leads out the prisoners to prosperity.” The mighty God who rides on the clouds is also the God of orphans and widows. His kingship is shown in his care for the vulnerable. The “solitary” are the lonely, and God places them in families. This is a theme of adoption, and the church is the household where it happens.

Verses 7 to 10 recall the exodus and Sinai, when the earth shook and the heavens poured down rain. God provided for his weary inheritance. Verses 11 to 14 refer to the conquest. Verses 15 to 17 describe Mount Zion, “the mount that God desired for his abode,” contrasted with the mountains of Bashan. And then the ascent: “The chariots of God are twice ten thousand, thousands upon thousands; the Lord is among them; Sinai is now in the sanctuary. You ascended on high, leading a host of captives in your train and receiving gifts among men, even among the rebellious, that the LORD God may dwell there.”

In the psalm, the picture is of a conquering king returning in triumph, with captives and tribute. Paul in Ephesians 4:8 quotes the verse with a small change: “he gave gifts to men.” Many interpreters explain that the conqueror receives tribute from the defeated and then distributes it to his people. Christ, having conquered sin, death, and Satan in the cross and resurrection, ascended and gave gifts to his church. The psalm foretold the ascension. Interestingly, the psalm adds that the gifts are received “even among the rebellious.” Even rebels are made into those who carry gifts, as Paul himself was a rebel turned apostle.

The psalm closes this section with a blessing: “Blessed be the Lord, who daily bears us up; God is our salvation.” Daily he carries his people. And “to GOD, the Lord, belong deliverances from death.” The final victory is his.

STEP 5

Connection

Numbers 10:35 is the opening line of the psalm. Ephesians 4:7-16 applies verse 18. Colossians 2:15 says Christ disarmed the rulers and authorities, triumphing over them in the cross. Acts 1:9-11 and 2:33 describe the ascension and the gift of the Spirit. Psalm 146:9 and Deuteronomy 10:18 also describe God's care for the fatherless. Hebrews 4:14 and 9:24 speak of Christ entering heaven. James 1:27 says pure religion is to care for orphans and widows. Judges 5 is another victory song.

STEP 6

Application

Look for a fatherless, widowed, or lonely person in your church or community. Make a place for them.

Thank Christ for the gifts he has given you. Name one and put it to use.

Pray verse 19: bless the Lord who daily bears us up.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to rise up and scatter his enemies.
- Thank him for being father of the fatherless and defender of widows.
- Thank him for giving gifts to his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 114

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

DAY 793 · WEEK 114

Psalm 110:1-7

The priest-king who ascended on high

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 110. You have read this psalm before, with Peter's sermons and Acts. Read it now with Ephesians in mind: it is the psalm of the ascended king, seated at God's right hand, who is also a priest forever.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 110 is the Old Testament verse most quoted in the New Testament. Jesus used it to stump the Pharisees (Matthew 22:41-46). Peter used it at Pentecost (Acts 2:34-35). The writer of Hebrews builds an entire argument on verse 4. In Ephesians 1:20-22, Paul draws on verse 1 when he says God seated Christ at his right hand, far above all rule and authority. Paired with Psalm 68, which describes the ascent, this psalm shows the seat and office of the ascended Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand" (v. 1).
2. "Until I make your enemies your footstool" (v. 1).
3. "The LORD sends forth from Zion your mighty scepter" (v. 2).
4. "Your people will offer themselves freely on the day of your power" (v. 3).
5. "The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind" (v. 4).
6. "You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek" (v. 4).
7. "He will shatter kings on the day of his wrath" (v. 5).
8. "Therefore he will lift up his head" (v. 7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a conversation within God. “The LORD says to my Lord.” David speaks of two: the LORD (Yahweh) and “my Lord” (Adonai), someone David himself calls Lord. Jesus pointed this out: “If David thus calls him Lord, how is he his son?” The answer is that the Messiah is both David’s descendant and David’s Lord, human and divine. The invitation: “Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool.” To sit at the right hand is to share the throne. Paul says this is where Christ now is (Ephesians 1:20; Colossians 3:1).

Verse 2 says the king rules from Zion in the midst of his enemies. His reign is real now, though not yet fully visible. Verse 3 describes his people: “Your people will offer themselves freely on the day of your power.” The king’s people are volunteers, willing servants. “In holy garments” (or splendor of holiness), they come like the dew of the morning. They are a new generation, drawn by the king’s power, not forced.

Verse 4 is the astonishing center: “The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind, You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek.” In Israel, kings came from Judah and priests from Levi. But here the king is also a priest, not of the Levitical order but of Melchizedek, the mysterious priest-king of Salem who blessed Abraham (Genesis 14:18-20). The writer of Hebrews explains that Christ is a high priest of a better order, with an oath, who lives forever and therefore has a permanent priesthood. Because he is a priest-king, he can intercede for us and rule us.

Verses 5 to 7 return to the king’s victories. The Lord at your right hand “will shatter kings on the day of his wrath. He will execute judgment among the nations.” This is the final judgment. The psalm ends, “He will drink from the brook by the way; therefore he will lift up his head.” The victorious king pauses to drink and goes on; his head is lifted in triumph. For Christians, the picture ties together the cross (the brook by the way, the suffering) and the exaltation.

Reading this psalm with Ephesians, we see that Christ’s ascension was not an absence but an enthronement. He now rules, intercedes, and gives gifts. We live between his ascension and his return, with confidence that he reigns.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 14:17-20 introduces Melchizedek. Matthew 22:41-46, Acts 2:29-36, and Hebrews 1:13, 5:6, 7:1-28 quote or use the psalm. Ephesians 1:20-23 and Colossians 3:1 speak of being seated at God’s right hand. 1 Corinthians 15:25 says he must reign until he has put all his enemies

under his feet. Zechariah 6:12-13 speaks of a priest on the throne. Revelation 19:11-16 shows the victorious king. Romans 8:34 says Christ is at the right hand of God, interceding for us. Psalm 2 is a companion royal psalm.

STEP 6

Application

Remember when anxious that Christ is seated at God's right hand, ruling all things.

Give thanks that your high priest lives forever to intercede for you.

Offer yourself freely to him today, as one of the willing people of verse 3.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for sitting at the Father's right hand.

Thank him that he is a priest forever.

Ask him to make his enemies his footstool in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 114

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

DAY 794 · WEEK 114

Philippians 1:1-2:30

Joy in prison; the Christ hymn; Timothy and Epaphroditus

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Philippians 1:1-2:30. Paul writes from prison, yet the letter is full of joy. Notice how he handles his imprisonment, the prayer he offers, the call to unity and humility, and the great Christ hymn in 2:5-11.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Philippi was a Roman colony in Macedonia where Paul planted the first church in Europe (Acts 16). The church had supported him generously. Now in prison, perhaps in Rome, he writes to thank them, to report on his situation, and to encourage them. Philippians has a repeated theme of joy; the words "joy" and "rejoice" appear about sixteen times. Its message is that joy does not depend on circumstances but on Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And I am sure of this, that he who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ" (1:6).
2. "I want you to know, brothers, that what has happened to me has really served to advance the gospel" (1:12).
3. "For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain" (1:21).
4. "Only let your manner of life be worthy of the gospel of Christ" (1:27).
5. "Do nothing from selfish ambition or conceit, but in humility count others more significant than yourselves" (2:3).
6. "Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus" (2:5).

7. “And every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father” (2:11).

8. “For it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure” (2:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul’s greeting includes “overseers and deacons.” He thanks God every time he remembers them, because of their partnership in the gospel from the first day. Then the great assurance of verse 6: “He who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ.” The Christian’s confidence rests on God’s faithfulness. He prays that their love may abound with knowledge and discernment, so that they may approve what is excellent and be filled with the fruit of righteousness.

Paul reports on his imprisonment. It has “really served to advance the gospel.” The whole imperial guard knows that his chains are for Christ, and most of the brothers have become more bold to speak the word without fear. Some preach Christ from envy and rivalry, others from good will. Paul’s response is remarkable: “What does it matter? Only that in every way, whether in pretense or in truth, Christ is proclaimed, and in that I rejoice.” The gospel is bigger than his reputation. Then he faces death honestly: “For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain.” He is torn between wanting to depart and be with Christ, which is far better, and remaining for their sake. He is convinced he will remain.

He calls them to unity and courage: “Only let your manner of life be worthy of the gospel of Christ… standing firm in one spirit, with one mind striving side by side for the faith of the gospel, and not frightened in anything by your opponents.” Suffering is a gift: “It has been granted to you that for the sake of Christ you should not only believe in him but also suffer for his sake.”

Then Paul calls for humility, with Christ as the model. “Do nothing from selfish ambition or conceit, but in humility count others more significant than yourselves. Let each of you look not only to his own interests, but also to the interests of others. Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus.” The hymn follows, which we will study in the next doctrinal pause: Christ, in the form of God, emptied himself, took the form of a servant, humbled himself to death on a cross; therefore God exalted him, and every knee will bow.

The practical conclusion: “Work out your own salvation with fear and trembling, for it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure. Do all things without grumbling or disputing, that you may be blameless and innocent, children of God without

blemish… among whom you shine as lights in the world, holding fast to the word of life." Paul also commends Timothy, who genuinely cares for their welfare, and Epaphroditus, who nearly died for the work of Christ. These are models of Christ's mind in action.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 16:11-40 tells of the founding of the Philippian church. Isaiah 45:22-23 is the source of 2:10-11. Romans 8:28 and 2 Corinthians 4:7-12 speak of God working in suffering. Philippians 4:10-20 speaks of their gift. John 13:1-17 shows Jesus' servant act. 1 Peter 2:21-25 calls us to follow his example. 2 Corinthians 8:9 speaks of his becoming poor. Matthew 5:14-16 calls us the light of the world. Hebrews 12:1-3 points to Jesus as pioneer and perfecter.

STEP 6

Application

Read the letter with an eye for the word "joy." Count how many times it appears.

Look for a way to count someone else more significant this week.

Entrust to God a work that you worry about. He who began it will complete it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for beginning a good work in you and bringing it to completion.

Tell him what it means that to live is Christ and to die is gain.

Ask him to give you Christ's humility.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 114

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

DAY 795 · WEEK 114

Philippians 2:5-11; Hebrews 2:14-18

Fully God and fully man

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Doctrine · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Philippians 2:5-11 and Hebrews 2:14-18. Today is a doctrinal pause on Christ as fully God and fully man. Read the Christ hymn slowly, perhaps several times. Notice what Christ was, what he did, and what God did in response.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Philippians 2:5-11 is often called the Christ hymn, and many scholars think it is an early Christian hymn or creed that Paul quotes. Hebrews 2 makes a similar point about Christ's humanity. The church fought for centuries to express this truth precisely. At the Council of Chalcedon in AD 451, it confessed that Christ is one person in two natures, truly God and truly man, without confusion, change, division, or separation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped" (Philippians 2:6).
2. "But emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men" (Philippians 2:7).
3. "And being found in human form, he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross" (Philippians 2:8).
4. "Therefore God has highly exalted him and bestowed on him the name that is above every name" (Philippians 2:9).
5. "And every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father" (Philippians 2:11).

6. “He himself likewise partook of the same things” (Hebrews 2:14).
7. “Therefore he had to be made like his brothers in every respect” (Hebrews 2:17).
8. “For because he himself has suffered when tempted, he is able to help those who are being tempted” (Hebrews 2:18).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The church confesses that Jesus Christ is fully God and fully man in one person. This is sometimes called the hypostatic union, or the doctrine of the two natures. It is the climax of the New Testament’s teaching about who Jesus is, and every other doctrine about him depends on it.

Fully God: The New Testament calls Jesus God (John 1:1; 20:28; Titus 2:13), gives him divine names, attributes, and works, and calls for worship of him. In Philippians 2:6, he existed “in the form of God” and had “equality with God.” Fully man: He was born of a woman, grew, hungered, thirsted, wept, was tempted, suffered, and died. He had a human body and a human soul. Hebrews insists he was made like us in every respect, except without sin (4:15). He is one person, not two. The same “I” who is God is the “I” who hungers.

Why does this matter? Because only a man could die for sinners, and only God could bear the infinite weight of sin and conquer death. A mediator between God and man must be both (1 Timothy 2:5). He represents us as one of us and reveals the Father as God. If Jesus is not fully God, he cannot save; if he is not fully man, he cannot save us as one of us. As Gregory of Nazianzus said, “What has not been assumed has not been healed.”

The phrase “emptied himself” (kenosis) has been debated. Orthodox interpretation holds that Christ did not cease to be God or lay aside any divine attribute, but emptied himself by taking on the form of a servant, veiling his glory, and voluntarily limiting the use of his divine prerogatives. He remained fully God while living as a real man. The main sense is not subtraction but addition: he added humanity to his deity. Some modern views claim that he gave up divine attributes; the church has rejected that as inconsistent with the biblical testimony.

The pattern of the hymn is humiliation and exaltation. He descended: from the form of God to the form of a servant, to death, to death on a cross. Then God exalted him with the name above every name, “Lord,” the name of God in the Greek Old Testament. Every knee will bow. This quotes Isaiah 45:23, where it is spoken of Yahweh. Paul applies it to Jesus.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul introduces the hymn to teach humility: “Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus.” The model of selfless love is Christ himself. “Though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped.” Christ did not hold onto the privileges of deity as something to exploit. “But emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men.” The Eternal Son took a human nature. “And being found in human form, he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross.” Crucifixion was the most shameful death. The Son of God went all the way down.

“Therefore God has highly exalted him.” The cross was not the end. The one who humbled himself is exalted. “The name that is above every name” is likely “Lord” (verse 11). “So that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.” Notice that the exaltation of Jesus brings glory to the Father, not rivalry. The whole creation, willingly or not, will acknowledge him.

Hebrews 2 covers the same ground from a different angle. “Since therefore the children share in flesh and blood, he himself likewise partook of the same things, that through death he might destroy the one who has the power of death, that is, the devil, and deliver all those who through fear of death were subject to lifelong slavery.” Christ became human in order to die, and he died in order to defeat death and free us from its fear. “Therefore he had to be made like his brothers in every respect, so that he might become a merciful and faithful high priest in the service of God, to make propitiation for the sins of the people. For because he himself has suffered when tempted, he is able to help those who are being tempted.” Jesus knows our weakness from the inside. We have a sympathetic high priest.

This is the gospel in its fullest form. God did not remain at a distance. He came near, became one of us, and gave himself for us. And now the one who suffered is reigning.

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:1-18 and Colossians 1:15-20 speak of the eternal Word becoming flesh. Isaiah 45:22-25 is the source of Philippians 2:10-11. Isaiah 52:13 to 53:12 foretells the servant’s humiliation and exaltation. Hebrews 4:14-16 speaks of the sympathetic high priest. 1 Timothy 2:5 speaks of one mediator. Romans 1:3-4 mentions both natures. 2 Corinthians 8:9 speaks of his becoming poor. Luke 2:52 says Jesus increased in wisdom and stature. Mark 13:32 shows the limits of his human knowledge. Acts 2:32-36 speaks of God making him Lord and Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Read the Christ hymn aloud each morning this week. Let it shape your attitude toward others.

When you are tempted or suffering, remember that Jesus knows what it is like. Go to him.

Bow the knee. Confess aloud, “Jesus Christ is Lord.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Worship Jesus, who was in the form of God and became a servant.

Thank him for becoming fully human to save you.

Ask him to give you his mindset.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 114

“Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.”

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

DAY 796 · WEEK 114

Philippians 3:1-4:23

Pressing on; contentment; the peace of God

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Philippians 3:1-4:23. Paul gives his own testimony, speaks of pressing on, and ends with practical commands about joy, prayer, peace, and contentment. Read 3:7-14 and 4:4-13 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In chapter 3, Paul warns the Philippians against those who trust in the flesh, including Judaizers who insisted on circumcision. He offers his own credentials and shows why he counts them as rubbish. Chapter 4 begins with a plea for two women in the church to be reconciled, followed by the best-known statements on joy, anxiety, and contentment. Paul wrote this in prison, which gives the commands special force.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Indeed, I count everything as loss because of the surpassing worth of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord” (3:8).
2. “That I may know him and the power of his resurrection, and may share his sufferings, becoming like him in his death” (3:10).
3. “I press on toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus” (3:14).
4. “Rejoice in the Lord always; again I will say, Rejoice” (4:4).
5. “Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God” (4:6).
6. “Whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is just” (4:8).
7. “I have learned in whatever situation I am to be content” (4:11).

8 “I can do all things through him who strengthens me” (4:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with a warning: “Look out for the dogs, look out for the evildoers, look out for those who mutilate the flesh. For we are the circumcision, who worship by the Spirit of God and glory in Christ Jesus and put no confidence in the flesh.” He then lists his own credentials: circumcised on the eighth day, of the people of Israel, of the tribe of Benjamin, a Hebrew of Hebrews, a Pharisee, a persecutor of the church, as to righteousness under the law blameless. “But whatever gain I had, I counted as loss for the sake of Christ. Indeed, I count everything as loss because of the surpassing worth of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord. For his sake I have suffered the loss of all things and count them as rubbish, in order that I may gain Christ and be found in him, not having a righteousness of my own that comes from the law, but that which comes through faith in Christ, the righteousness from God that depends on faith.” This is the gospel from his own heart.

The goal is to know Christ: “that I may know him and the power of his resurrection, and may share his sufferings, becoming like him in his death, that by any means possible I may attain the resurrection from the dead.” Paul has not yet arrived. “Brothers, I do not consider that I have made it my own. But one thing I do: forgetting what lies behind and straining forward to what lies ahead, I press on toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.” Like a runner, he keeps his eyes on the finish. He calls the mature to share this mindset and to imitate him. “But our citizenship is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ, who will transform our lowly body to be like his glorious body.”

Chapter 4 opens with a plea. Euodia and Syntyche, two women who labored beside Paul in the gospel, should agree in the Lord. Then the famous passage: “Rejoice in the Lord always; again I will say, Rejoice. Let your reasonableness be known to everyone. The Lord is at hand; do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.” Anxiety is replaced by prayer, and the result is peace that stands guard. Paul then directs the mind: “Whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is just, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is commendable, if there is any excellence, if there is anything worthy of praise, think about these things.”

He thanks them for their gift and reveals the secret of contentment: “I have learned in whatever situation I am to be content. I know how to be brought low, and I know how to abound. In any and every circumstance, I have learned the secret of facing plenty and hunger, abundance and need.” The secret: “I can do all things through him who strengthens

me." This verse is often misused as a promise of success in every endeavor. In context, it means Christ gives strength to endure any circumstance, whether abundance or need. He closes with a promise: "My God will supply every need of yours according to his riches in glory in Christ Jesus."

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 3:21-26 and Galatians 2:15-21 expand on a righteousness from God by faith. 1 Corinthians 9:24-27 and 2 Timothy 4:7 also use the race image. Colossians 3:1-4 speaks of citizenship and the heavenly life. Matthew 6:25-34 teaches not to be anxious. 1 Peter 5:7 says to cast all your anxieties on him. 1 Timothy 6:6-10 speaks of godliness with contentment. Hebrews 13:5 says be content with what you have. 2 Corinthians 12:9-10 gives Christ's strength in weakness. Isaiah 26:3 promises perfect peace.

STEP 6

Application

When anxiety comes, turn each worry into a specific prayer with thanksgiving.

Think on the list of verse 8 for ten minutes. Write down things that fit each description.

Ask what you need to count as loss for the sake of knowing Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell Jesus that you count everything as loss compared to knowing him.

Ask him to help you press on toward the goal.

Give him your anxieties with thanksgiving.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 114

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

DAY 797 · WEEK 114

Colossians 1:1-2:5

Christ above all; the cosmic Christ; the mystery

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Colossians 1:1-2:5. This is the great passage on the supremacy of Christ. Read verses 15-20 slowly and several times. Then notice how Paul describes his own ministry of suffering and labor.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul wrote Colossians from prison to a church he had not founded, in a town in the Lycus Valley near Laodicea and Hierapolis. Epaphras had planted the church and brought news of a developing heresy. The false teaching mixed Jewish regulations, mystical visions, angel worship, and ascetic practices with a diminished view of Christ. Paul's answer is not a list of rules but a magnificent portrait of Christ as supreme over everything.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son" (1:13).
2. "He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation" (1:15).
3. "For by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible" (1:16).
4. "And he is before all things, and in him all things hold together" (1:17).
5. "And he is the head of the body, the church. He is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead, that in everything he might be preeminent" (1:18).
6. "Making peace by the blood of his cross" (1:20).
7. "Christ in you, the hope of glory" (1:27).

8 “In whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge” (2:3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul greets the church, thanks God for their faith, love, and hope, and prays that they would be filled with the knowledge of God’s will in all spiritual wisdom and understanding, to walk in a manner worthy of the Lord, fully pleasing to him, bearing fruit, increasing in the knowledge of God, strengthened with all power, joyfully giving thanks to the Father. And he states what God has done: “He has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son, in whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins.”

Then the hymn to Christ in verses 15 to 20. In the first stanza, Christ is supreme over creation. “He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation. For by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities, all things were created through him and for him. And he is before all things, and in him all things hold together.” “Image” means that he perfectly shows God. “Firstborn” is a title of rank and inheritance, not of being created: he is the heir and sovereign over creation, as the creator of it. Everything was made by him, through him, and for him. He holds the universe together. No angel, spirit, or power rivals him.

In the second stanza, Christ is supreme over the new creation. “He is the head of the body, the church. He is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead, that in everything he might be preeminent. For in him all the fullness of God was pleased to dwell, and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether on earth or in heaven, making peace by the blood of his cross.” The creator is the redeemer. The same Christ who made all things is reconciling all things. The cross is the means of cosmic peace. Notice that “all the fullness of God” dwells in him.

Then Paul applies it to the Colossians: once alienated and hostile in mind, doing evil deeds, they have been reconciled in his body of flesh by his death, “in order to present you holy and blameless and above reproach before him, if indeed you continue in the faith.” Perseverance is the evidence of reality.

Paul describes his own ministry. He rejoices in his sufferings for their sake, “and in my flesh I am filling up what is lacking in Christ’s afflictions for the sake of his body, that is, the church.” This does not mean Christ’s atonement is incomplete; rather, Paul’s sufferings as an apostle extend Christ’s afflictions into the world as the gospel is spread. The mystery now revealed is “Christ in you, the hope of glory.” He proclaims Christ, warning everyone and teaching everyone in all wisdom, that he may present everyone mature in Christ. Chapter 2

begins with his struggle for them, that their hearts may be encouraged, knit together in love, to reach all the riches of full assurance of understanding and of knowing the mystery of God, "in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge."

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1 and Proverbs 8:22-31 stand behind the creation language. John 1:1-3 and Hebrews 1:1-4 are parallel statements. Isaiah 45:18 and Psalm 33:6 speak of God as creator. Revelation 1:5 calls Jesus the firstborn of the dead. Romans 8:19-23 speaks of creation's renewal. Ephesians 1:10 and 2:11-22 speak of uniting all things. 2 Corinthians 5:18-21 speaks of reconciliation. Philippians 2:5-11 is a related hymn. Galatians 2:20 speaks of Christ living in us.

STEP 6

Application

Read Colossians 1:15-20 aloud once a day this week. Let it enlarge your view of Christ.

Where do you feel small in the face of problems? Remember that he holds all things together.

Ask what it means for you that Christ is "preeminent in everything." What area of your life does he not yet lead?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship Jesus as the image of the invisible God.
- Thank him that in him all things hold together.
- Tell him what you want to give him preeminence over.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 114

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

DAY 798 · WEEK 114

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Philippians 4:6-7 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

REST

Meditation

These verses are Paul's prescription for anxiety. They are written by a man in prison.

"Do not be anxious about anything." The command is wide: about anything. Paul does not say that we will never feel worry, but that we should not live in it. Anxiety divides the mind and assumes that everything depends on us.

"But in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving." The alternative to worry is prayer. Prayer is the general word; supplication is the specific asking for needs. Thanksgiving is included, because it reminds us of God's faithfulness in the past and shifts our focus from what we lack.

“Let your requests be made known to God.” Be specific. God knows already, but he invites us to say it. Bring the actual worries by name.

“And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.” Notice the promise: it is not that the circumstances will necessarily change but that peace will stand guard like a soldier at the gate. It is a peace that does not make sense from the outside. It is found “in Christ Jesus.”

When anxiety rises, pray this verse, and turn each worry into a request with thanks.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you moved from Ephesians into Philippians and Colossians. Psalms 68 and 110 showed the ascended Christ, who leads captives, gives gifts, and sits at God’s right hand as priest-king. Philippians showed joy in prison: the gospel advances through chains, Christ is the model of humility, and God works in us both to will and to work. A doctrinal pause on the Christ hymn considered that Jesus is fully God and fully man in one person, who emptied himself, took the form of a servant, and was exalted to the name above every name. Philippians 3 and 4 showed the surpassing worth of knowing Christ, pressing on toward the goal, praying instead of worrying, and the secret of contentment in Christ who strengthens us. Colossians 1 and 2 presented the supremacy of Christ: image of the invisible God, creator and sustainer of all things, head of the church, reconciler by the blood of his cross, and Christ in us, the hope of glory.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says to be anxious about nothing and to pray about everything. What is one worry you need to turn into a specific prayer right now? Take a few minutes and do it.

Colossians 1:15-20 says Christ is supreme over creation and over the church. Where in your life do you treat Christ as less than preeminent? What would it look like to give him first place?

Philippians 3 says Paul counted all his credentials as loss for the sake of knowing Christ. What do you trust in besides Christ for your standing, identity, or security? What would it look like to let it go?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for being supreme and for being your peace.

Thank him for the peace of God that guards your heart and mind.

Rest in him.

DAY 799 · WEEK 115

Colossians 2:6-3:17

Don't be taken captive; the new self; let Christ's word dwell

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Colossians 2:6-3:17. Paul warns against being taken captive by empty philosophy and then gives the positive vision: you have died and been raised with Christ, so put off the old and put on the new. Read 3:1-17 slowly, as a portrait of the Christian life.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After exalting Christ in chapter 1, Paul addresses the false teaching in Colosse. It seems to have included regulations about food, drink, festivals, and Sabbaths; visions and worship of angels; and severe treatment of the body. Paul's answer is that all of this is only a shadow, and the substance is Christ. Then he turns to the new life, which is based on union with Christ in his death and resurrection.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "See to it that no one takes you captive by philosophy and empty deceit, according to human tradition" (2:8).
2. "For in him the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily" (2:9).
3. "By canceling the record of debt that stood against us with its legal demands" (2:14).
4. "These are a shadow of the things to come, but the substance belongs to Christ" (2:17).
5. "If then you have been raised with Christ, seek the things that are above, where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God" (3:1).
6. "For you have died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God" (3:3).
7. "And above all these put on love, which binds everything together in perfect harmony" (3:14).

8 “Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly, teaching and admonishing one another in all wisdom” (3:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with the basic instruction: “As you received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk in him, rooted and built up in him and established in the faith, just as you were taught, abounding in thanksgiving.” The Christian life continues as it began: with Christ. Then the warning: “See to it that no one takes you captive by philosophy and empty deceit, according to human tradition, according to the elemental spirits of the world, and not according to Christ.” Not all philosophy is wrong, but any teaching that adds to or displaces Christ is empty. The reason: “For in him the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily, and you have been filled in him, who is the head of all rule and authority.” If you have Christ, you have everything.

Next, what Christ has done. In him you were circumcised with a circumcision made without hands, buried with him in baptism and raised with him through faith in the powerful working of God. “And you, who were dead in your trespasses… God made alive together with him, having forgiven us all our trespasses, by canceling the record of debt that stood against us with its legal demands. This he set aside, nailing it to the cross.” The debt-record that condemned us was nailed to the cross. “He disarmed the rulers and authorities and put them to open shame, by triumphing over them in him.” The powers have been defeated.

So Paul says: “Let no one pass judgment on you in questions of food and drink, or with regard to a festival or a new moon or a Sabbath. These are a shadow of the things to come, but the substance belongs to Christ.” The old covenant regulations pointed forward to Christ, and now that the reality has come, we are not bound to the shadow. This is a significant text in understanding the relationship between the covenants. Christians differ on how it bears on the Sabbath, but all agree it clarifies that no ritual observance contributes to our standing before God. Rules that appear wise, like “Do not handle, Do not taste, Do not touch,” have no value in stopping the indulgence of the flesh.

Chapter 3 begins with “If then you have been raised with Christ.” The resurrection has practical consequences. “Seek the things that are above, where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God. Set your minds on things that are above, not on things that are on earth. For you have died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God. When Christ who is your life appears, then you also will appear with him in glory.” Our true life is secured in heaven.

Then the practical: “Put to death therefore what is earthly in you: sexual immorality, impurity, passion, evil desire, and covetousness, which is idolatry.” Put away anger, wrath, malice, slander, obscene talk, and lying. These belong to the old self. “Put on then, as God’s

chosen ones, holy and beloved, compassionate hearts, kindness, humility, meekness, and patience, bearing with one another and, if one has a complaint against another, forgiving each other; as the Lord has forgiven you, so you also must forgive. And above all these put on love, which binds everything together in perfect harmony. And let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts." Finally, "Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly, teaching and admonishing one another in all wisdom, singing psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, with thankfulness in your hearts to God. And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 6:1-14 speaks of union with Christ in death and resurrection. Ephesians 4:17-32 and Galatians 5:16-26 are parallels on putting off and putting on. Isaiah 61:10 speaks of being clothed in righteousness. Hebrews 8:5, 10:1 describe the law as a shadow. Mark 7:14-23 shows Jesus on clean and unclean. Matthew 6:19-21 says set your treasure in heaven. 1 Peter 2:9 speaks of God's chosen ones. Philippians 3:20-21 speaks of heavenly citizenship. Psalm 119:11 speaks of treasuring the word.

STEP 6

Application

Read Colossians 3:12-17 aloud as a list of clothes. Put on one piece today.

Set your mind on things above for a few minutes at the start of the day.

Ask what "rules" you have made that are not from Christ. Where do you trust a shadow?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that in him the whole fullness of deity dwells, and that you have been filled in him.

Ask him to help you set your mind on things above.

Ask him to let his word dwell in you richly.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 115

“And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him.”

COLOSSIANS 3:17

DAY 800 · WEEK 115

Colossians 3:18-4:18

Household codes; final greetings

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Colossians 3:18-4:18. Paul gives instructions for households and for the church's witness, then ends with a long list of greetings. Notice the Christ-centered grounds of each command and the picture of the church as a network of friends and coworkers.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has described the new life in Christ in general terms. Now he applies it to the most ordinary relationships of daily life: marriage, parents and children, work. He addresses each party in the relationship, treating all as accountable to the Lord. This is a significant feature: the instructions about households, which echo Ephesians 5 and 6, give moral responsibility to all, including children and slaves, and warn masters. The letter ends with a list of names that shows the early church as a living community.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Husbands, love your wives, and do not be harsh with them" (3:19).
2. "Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord and not for men" (3:23).
3. "Masters, treat your bondservants justly and fairly, knowing that you also have a Master in heaven" (4:1).
4. "Continue steadfastly in prayer, being watchful in it with thanksgiving" (4:2).
5. "At the same time pray also for us, that God may open to us a door for the word, to declare the mystery of Christ" (4:3).
6. "Let your speech always be gracious, seasoned with salt, so that you may know how you ought to answer each person" (4:6).

7. “Luke the beloved physician greets you” (4:14).

8. “Remember my chains. Grace be with you” (4:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The household code in Colossians is shorter than in Ephesians but follows the same pattern. “Wives, submit to your husbands, as is fitting in the Lord. Husbands, love your wives, and do not be harsh with them.” The word for “harsh” means bitter or embittered. The husband’s role is love, not domination. “Children, obey your parents in everything, for this pleases the Lord. Fathers, do not provoke your children, lest they become discouraged.” Discouragement is a real danger in children, and fathers are responsible not to cause it.

To slaves, Paul gives the longest instruction. “Bondservants, obey in everything those who are your earthly masters, not with eye-service, as people-pleasers, but with sincerity of heart, fearing the Lord. Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord and not for men, knowing that from the Lord you will receive the inheritance as your reward. You are serving the Lord Christ.” This is a transformative vision of work, which we will explore on the doctrinal pause. “For the wrongdoer will be paid back for the wrong he has done, and there is no partiality.” Then to masters: “treat your bondservants justly and fairly, knowing that you also have a Master in heaven.” Paul does not endorse slavery. He addresses people within a social system and weakens it from within, as Philemon will show.

Paul then calls the church to prayer and witness. “Continue steadfastly in prayer, being watchful in it with thanksgiving.” He asks for prayer for himself and his coworkers: “that God may open to us a door for the word, to declare the mystery of Christ, on account of which I am in prison, that I may make it clear, which is how I ought to speak.” Imprisoned, he does not pray for release but for opportunities to preach. And the church’s own witness: “Walk in wisdom toward outsiders, making the best use of the time. Let your speech always be gracious, seasoned with salt, so that you may know how you ought to answer each person.” Gracious, not flat; seasoned, not bland.

The closing section is a roll call. Tychicus, “a beloved brother and faithful minister and fellow servant in the Lord,” will tell them everything about Paul, with Onesimus, “who is one of you.” Aristarchus, Mark (the cousin of Barnabas, now restored to Paul’s favor), Jesus called Justus. Epaphras, who is “always struggling on your behalf in his prayers.” Luke the beloved physician, and Demas, who will later desert him (2 Timothy 4:10). Nympha and the church in her house. And a message for Archippus: “See that you fulfill the ministry that you have received in the Lord.” The letter ends: “I, Paul, write this greeting with my own hand. Remember my chains. Grace be with you.” Behind the doctrine are people with names and stories.

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 5:22 to 6:9 is the parallel. 1 Peter 2:18 to 3:7 also addresses households. Philemon applies the teaching to a specific case. Acts 12:12 and 15:36-41 tell of Mark. Acts 20:4 mentions Tychicus. 2 Timothy 4:10-11 mentions Demas and Luke. Philemon 23-24 repeats several of these names. Revelation 3:14-22 addresses Laodicea. Proverbs 15:1 and 25:11 speak of wise speech. Luke 12:35-48 speaks of service to the master.

STEP 6

Application

Name the people in your life whom you serve in a relationship of authority or dependence. Treat each as someone who answers to the Lord.

Pray for a door for the gospel with someone this week. Pray also for your speech to be gracious and salty.

Write a note of thanks to a faithful fellow worker, like Tychicus.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you do whatever you do heartily, as for him.
- Ask him to bless your household and your workplace.
- Ask him to give you wisdom and gracious words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 115

"And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."

COLOSSIANS 3:17

DAY 801 · WEEK 115

1 Corinthians 7:17-24; Colossians 3:22-4:1

Ordinary work as service to God

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Doctrine · 15 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 7:17-24 and Colossians 3:22-4:1. Today is a doctrinal pause on ordinary work as service to God, also called vocation or calling. Notice that Paul speaks to people whose jobs were not their choice, and he still says that they serve the Lord Christ.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Most Christians spend most of their waking hours at work, in the home, or in the community, not in church. What does the gospel say about that? In the first century, a large portion of believers were slaves or workers in humble occupations. Paul does not tell them that real service to God is elsewhere. He tells them that their ordinary labor, done for Christ, is service to God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Only let each person lead the life that the Lord has assigned to him, and to which God has called him” (1 Corinthians 7:17).
2. “For he who was called in the Lord as a bondservant is a freedman of the Lord” (1 Corinthians 7:22).
3. “You were bought with a price; do not become slaves of men” (1 Corinthians 7:23).
4. “So, brothers, in whatever condition each was called, there let him remain with God” (1 Corinthians 7:24).

5. “Not with eye-service, as people-pleasers, but with sincerity of heart, fearing the Lord” (Colossians 3:22).
6. “Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord and not for men” (Colossians 3:23).
7. “You are serving the Lord Christ” (Colossians 3:24).
8. “Masters, treat your bondservants justly and fairly, knowing that you also have a Master in heaven” (Colossians 4:1).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The doctrine of vocation says that God calls his people not only to salvation but also to places of service in the world, and that ordinary work is a way of loving God and neighbor. The word “calling” in the New Testament primarily refers to God’s call to salvation in Christ, as in 1 Corinthians 7:17-24, where Paul speaks of the condition in which each was called. By extension, Christians have understood that God also places us in occupations, families, churches, and communities where we serve him.

During the Reformation, Martin Luther emphasized that the farmer, the mother, the magistrate, and the cobbler serve God as much as the monk or priest. Before, many believed that spiritual work was reserved for clergy. Luther said that God milks cows through the hands of milkmaids. The Reformers taught that all legitimate work is a calling, and that we serve God by serving others in it. In the Reformed tradition, this became a doctrine of the cultural mandate: from Genesis 1:28 and 2:15, human beings were made to work, tend, and cultivate the creation. Work was part of paradise; the fall made it toilsome (Genesis 3:17-19), but redemption restores its dignity.

Three truths follow. First, the Lord is the real boss. “You are serving the Lord Christ.” This gives dignity to menial jobs and removes the excuse of poor management, since our ultimate employer sees and rewards. Second, work is for others. Ephesians 4:28 says the thief should work with his hands “so that he may have something to share with anyone in need.” Work serves the neighbor and the common good. Third, our identity is not in our work. We are first called to Christ. This frees us from both pride in achievement and despair in failure.

The passage on slavery requires care. Paul is not endorsing slavery as an institution. The New Testament never commands it and regards the slave trade as sin (1 Timothy 1:10). He gives instructions to people living within it. At the same time, he undermines it: slaves are addressed as moral agents with an inheritance from the Lord, masters are told they have a Master in heaven, and in 1 Corinthians 7:21 he adds, “if you can gain your freedom, avail

yourself of the opportunity." Philemon, which you will read soon, calls a master to receive a slave as a beloved brother. The Christian gospel, taken to its conclusion, led believers to oppose slavery.

Christians also differ on how much to emphasize staying in one's condition (1 Corinthians 7:20, 24) versus pursuing change. Paul's point is that your condition does not determine your standing with God, not that you can never change it.

STEP 4

Interpretation

In 1 Corinthians 7, Paul has been addressing marriage and singleness. He gives a general rule: "Only let each person lead the life that the Lord has assigned to him, and to which God has called him. This is my rule in all the churches." Circumcised or uncircumcised, it does not matter; keeping God's commandments is what matters. "Each one should remain in the condition in which he was called." Were you a slave when called? "Do not be concerned about it. (But if you can gain your freedom, avail yourself of the opportunity.) For he who was called in the Lord as a bondservant is a freedman of the Lord. Likewise he who was free when called is a bondservant of Christ. You were bought with a price; do not become slaves of men." The gospel gives a new status that cannot be taken away. A slave is the Lord's freedman; a free person is Christ's slave. The social ranking is secondary.

In Colossians 3, Paul turns to practical conduct. "Bondservants, obey in everything those who are your earthly masters, not with eye-service, as people-pleasers, but with sincerity of heart, fearing the Lord." Eye-service is working only when the boss is watching. "Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord and not for men, knowing that from the Lord you will receive the inheritance as your reward. You are serving the Lord Christ." The slave had no legal rights, but Paul tells him that he has an inheritance, which the free would normally receive. The reward is not wages but the inheritance of the sons of God. In a world where slaves were considered tools, this was radical.

The principle applies to every honest job. Whatever you do, do it heartily. The Christian employee, student, parent, teacher, cleaner, or executive works for a higher Lord. This changes how we work (with diligence), why we work (for his glory and others' good), and how we rest (in his provision). Mundane tasks are holy when done to the Lord.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:28 and 2:15 give the work mandate. Genesis 3:17-19 describes the toil after the fall. Exodus 31:1-6 describes the Spirit-filled craftsmen. Proverbs 6:6-11 and 22:29 praise diligent work. Ephesians 4:28 and 6:5-9 speak of work and slaves. 2 Thessalonians 3:6-12 warns

against idleness. 1 Corinthians 10:31 says do all to the glory of God. Philemon is the test case. Psalm 90:17 prays for the work of our hands to be established. Matthew 25:14-30 teaches faithfulness in what we have been given.

STEP 6

Application

Do your next task today as if Christ were your employer. Notice what changes.

Thank God for the occupation he has given you, even if it's imperfect.

Think about someone whose work is invisible, like a janitor or a caregiver. Honor them this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the work he has given you, and tell him what it is.
- Ask him to help you work heartily, as for the Lord.
- Ask him to show you how your ordinary work can serve him and others.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 115

"And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."

COLOSSIANS 3:17

DAY 802 · WEEK 115

1 Thessalonians 1:1-3:13

A model church; Paul's care; the apostle's heart

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Thessalonians 1:1-3:13. This is probably Paul's earliest letter. Read it as a warm letter from a spiritual father to young believers. Notice the model they set, the way Paul describes his ministry, and the way he longs to see them.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul planted the church in Thessalonica, the capital of Macedonia, on his second journey (Acts 17:1-9). He stayed only a few weeks before being driven out by a mob. Anxious about the young believers, he sent Timothy back; when Timothy returned with good news, Paul wrote this letter from Corinth around AD 50. It is full of encouragement, with gratitude, defense of his ministry against slander, and comfort. The Thessalonians were facing persecution and questions about those who had died.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Remembering before our God and Father your work of faith and labor of love and steadfastness of hope in our Lord Jesus Christ" (1:3).
2. "Because our gospel came to you not only in word, but also in power and in the Holy Spirit and with full conviction" (1:5).
3. "How you turned to God from idols to serve the living and true God, and to wait for his Son from heaven" (1:9-10).
4. "But we were gentle among you, like a nursing mother taking care of her own children" (2:7).
5. "We were ready to share with you not only the gospel of God but also our own selves" (2:8).

6. “You accepted it not as the word of men but as what it really is, the word of God, which is at work in you believers” (2:13).
7. “For now we live, if you are standing fast in the Lord” (3:8).
8. “And may the Lord make you increase and abound in love for one another and for all” (3:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The letter opens with thanksgiving. Paul remembers their “work of faith and labor of love and steadfastness of hope,” the great triad of faith, love, and hope. He knows God chose them because the gospel came “not only in word, but also in power and in the Holy Spirit and with full conviction.” They became imitators of Paul and the Lord, receiving the word in much affliction with the joy of the Holy Spirit, and became an example to all the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. The word of the Lord sounded forth from them. Everyone reports how they “turned to God from idols to serve the living and true God, and to wait for his Son from heaven, whom he raised from the dead, Jesus who delivers us from the wrath to come.” A model church: converted, serving, and waiting.

In chapter 2, Paul describes his ministry. The accusations probably were that he was a charlatan who preached for money or praise. He replies with the facts: they were bold to speak the gospel in spite of suffering at Philippi. They did not speak with error or impure motives or deceit. They were not trying to please men but God who tests the heart. They did not use flattery or greed or seek glory. “But we were gentle among you, like a nursing mother taking care of her own children.” Then, as a father, “exhorting each one of you and encouraging you and charging you to walk in a manner worthy of God, who calls you into his own kingdom and glory.” Paul’s ministry combines maternal tenderness and paternal firmness. They worked night and day so as not to burden anyone.

“And we also thank God constantly for this, that when you received the word of God, which you heard from us, you accepted it not as the word of men but as what it really is, the word of God, which is at work in you believers.” This is a key statement about preaching: faithful preaching of Scripture is the word of God. The Thessalonians suffered from their own countrymen, as the churches in Judea did from the Jews. Paul longed to see them and was hindered by Satan. “For what is our hope or joy or crown of boasting before our Lord Jesus at his coming? Is it not you?”

In chapter 3, Paul explains that he sent Timothy to strengthen them in their faith, lest they be shaken by afflictions. When Timothy returned with news of their faith and love, Paul was comforted. “For now we live, if you are standing fast in the Lord.” The prayer: “Now may our God and Father himself, and our Lord Jesus, direct our way to you, and may the Lord make

you increase and abound in love for one another and for all, as we do for you, so that he may establish your hearts blameless in holiness before our God and Father, at the coming of our Lord Jesus with all his saints." Ministry is love expressed in prayer and labor.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 17:1-15 tells of the Thessalonian mission. Philippians 4:15-16 mentions their gifts. 2 Corinthians 11:9 records provision from Macedonia. 1 Corinthians 13:13 pairs faith, hope, and love. Hebrews 4:12 speaks of the word of God living and active. 2 Timothy 3:16-17 teaches that all Scripture is God-breathed. Matthew 24:13 and John 15:18-20 speak of enduring persecution. Romans 8:35-39 assures of Christ's love in suffering. Colossians 1:3-8 reflects similar thanksgiving.

STEP 6

Application

Thank someone who led you to Christ or taught you in the faith. Tell them.

Ask whether you are a model for others, in how you turned to God, serve, and wait.

Receive Scripture today as the word of God, which is at work in you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for people who work in faith, labor in love, and endure in hope.

Ask him to help you be that kind of person.

Thank him for those who showed you how.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 115

"And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."

COLOSSIANS 3:17

DAY 803 · WEEK 115

1 Thessalonians 4:13-18; Matthew 24:30-31; Revelation 1:7

The Return of Christ

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18, Matthew 24:30-31, and Revelation 1:7. Today is a doctrinal pause on the return of Christ. Notice how Paul comforts grieving believers, and how Jesus and John describe his coming.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first Christians lived in expectation of Christ's return. The Thessalonians, new believers, were distressed because some of their number had died before he returned. Would they miss out? Paul writes to correct their ignorance and to comfort them. The second coming of Christ is one of the most frequently repeated promises of the New Testament, and it shapes how Christians live, pray, grieve, and hope.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But we do not want you to be uninformed, brothers, about those who are asleep, that you may not grieve as others do who have no hope" (1 Thessalonians 4:13).
2. "For since we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so, through Jesus, God will bring with him those who have fallen asleep" (1 Thessalonians 4:14).
3. "For the Lord himself will descend from heaven with a cry of command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God" (1 Thessalonians 4:16).
4. "Then we who are alive, who are left, will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air, and so we will always be with the Lord" (1 Thessalonians 4:17).

5. “Therefore encourage one another with these words” (1 Thessalonians 4:18).
6. “Then will appear in heaven the sign of the Son of Man” (Matthew 24:30).
7. “And he will send out his angels with a loud trumpet call, and they will gather his elect from the four winds” (Matthew 24:31).
8. “Behold, he is coming with the clouds, and every eye will see him” (Revelation 1:7).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The return of Christ, often called the second coming, is the promise that Jesus will come again, personally, visibly, bodily, and gloriously, at the end of the age, to raise the dead, judge the world, and establish his kingdom in its fullness. The angels said at the ascension, “This Jesus, who was taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you saw him go into heaven” (Acts 1:11). It is the “blessed hope” of the church (Titus 2:13).

Several features are clear. It will be personal: “the Lord himself will descend.” It will be visible and public: “every eye will see him.” It will be glorious, with a cry of command, the voice of an archangel, and the trumpet of God. It will be sudden: “like a thief in the night.” The timing is unknown: not even the angels or the Son know the day or hour (Matthew 24:36). Therefore we are to be ready and watchful. It will bring the resurrection of believers and the transformation of those still alive. It will bring judgment on the living and the dead, and it will complete salvation: the new creation, the end of death, and God dwelling with his people.

Christians have held different views about the details, especially regarding the “rapture” (being caught up in the air) and the millennium. Some hold that Christ will return before a thousand-year reign (premillennialism), with differing views on whether the church goes through the great tribulation. Others hold that the millennium is the present reign of Christ in heaven and with his church (amillennialism). Others hold that the church will bring about a golden age before his return (postmillennialism). These differences matter less than the shared hope: Christ is coming, visibly, to raise the dead, judge, and make all things new. We should hold such details with humility and avoid date-setting.

The doctrine has practical effects. It comforts the grieving: we will see our loved ones in Christ again. It motivates holiness: “everyone who thus hopes in him purifies himself as he is pure” (1 John 3:3). It encourages mission, because the gospel must be preached to all nations before the end. It also sobers us because judgment is coming. And it makes us watchful and active.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul writes, “We do not want you to be uninformed, brothers, about those who are asleep, that you may not grieve as others do who have no hope.” Christians do grieve, but not as those without hope. “For since we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so, through Jesus, God will bring with him those who have fallen asleep.” The resurrection of Jesus is the guarantee of ours.

Then he explains by “a word from the Lord”: “We who are alive, who are left until the coming of the Lord, will not precede those who have fallen asleep. For the Lord himself will descend from heaven with a cry of command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. Then we who are alive, who are left, will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air, and so we will always be with the Lord.” The picture is of a welcoming party: when a king visited a city, citizens went out to meet him and escort him back in. We rise to meet the Lord and come with him. “Therefore encourage one another with these words.” The doctrine of Christ’s return is meant for comfort.

Jesus himself speaks in Matthew 24 of the sign of the Son of Man appearing in heaven, and all the tribes of the earth mourning as they see the Son of Man coming on the clouds with power and great glory. He will send out his angels with a loud trumpet call, and they will gather his elect from the four winds. This echoes Daniel 7:13-14. For those who have rejected him, his coming means mourning; for his people, it means gathering.

John, in Revelation 1:7, combines Daniel 7:13 and Zechariah 12:10: “Behold, he is coming with the clouds, and every eye will see him, even those who pierced him, and all tribes of the earth will wail on account of him. Even so. Amen.” The same Jesus who was pierced will return. The right response is to say “Amen” and “Come, Lord Jesus.”

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 7:13-14 and Zechariah 12:10 stand behind the language. Acts 1:9-11 gives the promise at the ascension. Matthew 24:36 to 25:46 includes Jesus’ teaching on being ready. John 14:1-3 promises, “I will come again and take you to myself.” 1 Corinthians 15:51-58 describes the change. Philippians 3:20-21 speaks of our heavenly citizenship. Titus 2:11-14 speaks of the blessed hope. 2 Peter 3:3-13 answers scoffers. Revelation 19:11-16 and 22:20 describe his coming and the church’s cry.

STEP 6

Application

Share verse 18 with someone who is grieving: “Encourage one another with these words.”

Ask whether you live as if Christ may come today. What would you change?

Pray, “Come, Lord Jesus,” as part of your prayers this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that he will return with a shout.

Tell him how you feel about his coming, and ask him to make you ready.

Ask him to give you hope and comfort for those who have died in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 115

“And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him.”

COLOSSIANS 3:17

DAY 804 · WEEK 115

1 Thessalonians 4:1-5:28

Holy living; the coming of the Lord; final exhortations

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 46 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Thessalonians 4:1-5:28. Paul gives instruction on holy living, brotherly love, the day of the Lord, and a series of brief final exhortations. Notice how many of the commands are short and practical.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Having celebrated the church and defended his ministry, Paul turns to instruction. He urges the Thessalonians to live in holiness, to love one another, and to work quietly. Then, after the comfort of 4:13-18, he adds a warning and encouragement about the day of the Lord: how to live in the meantime. The letter ends with a rapid-fire list of commands that summarize the Christian life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “And to aspire to live quietly, and to mind your own affairs, and to work with your hands” (4:11).
2. “For you yourselves are fully aware that the day of the Lord will come like a thief in the night” (5:2).
3. “But since we belong to the day, let us be sober, having put on the breastplate of faith and love, and for a helmet the hope of salvation” (5:8).
4. “For God has not destined us for wrath, but to obtain salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ” (5:9).
5. “Therefore encourage one another and build one another up, just as you are doing” (5:11).

6. “Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances” (5:16-18).
7. “Test everything; hold fast what is good” (5:21).
8. “He who calls you is faithful; he will surely do it” (5:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 4 opens with a call to please God more and more. “For this is the will of God, your sanctification: that you abstain from sexual immorality; that each of you know how to control his own body in holiness and honor.” God has called us in holiness, and he gives his Holy Spirit. Regarding brotherly love, Paul says they have been taught by God and are doing it, but to do so more and more. He adds a practical word: “aspire to live quietly, and to mind your own affairs, and to work with your hands, as we instructed you, so that you may walk properly before outsiders and be dependent on no one.” Some had apparently stopped working in expectation of Christ’s return. Hope does not cancel responsibility.

After the passage on the return of Christ (see the doctrinal pause), chapter 5 addresses “the times and the seasons.” Believers do not need instruction about dates, “for you yourselves are fully aware that the day of the Lord will come like a thief in the night. While people are saying, There is peace and security, then sudden destruction will come upon them.” But believers are not in darkness. “For you are all children of light, children of the day.” So the response: “Let us not sleep, as others do, but let us keep awake and be sober.” The armor is faith and love as a breastplate and the hope of salvation as a helmet. “For God has not destined us for wrath, but to obtain salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ, who died for us so that whether we are awake or asleep we might live with him. Therefore encourage one another and build one another up.”

Then a rapid series of commands. Respect those who labor among you and are over you in the Lord; esteem them highly in love because of their work. Be at peace among yourselves. Admonish the idle, encourage the fainthearted, help the weak, be patient with all. “See that no one repays anyone evil for evil, but always seek to do good to one another and to everyone.” And the famous three: “Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you.” These are not a requirement to feel happy always but a settled posture toward God. “Do not quench the Spirit. Do not despise prophecies, but test everything; hold fast what is good. Abstain from every form of evil.”

The prayer: “Now may the God of peace himself sanctify you completely, and may your whole spirit and soul and body be kept blameless at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ. He who calls you is faithful; he will surely do it.” Holiness is ultimately God’s work. The letter

ends: “Pray for us. Greet all the brothers with a holy kiss. I put you under oath before the Lord to have this letter read to all the brothers. The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you.”

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 19:2 and 1 Peter 1:15-16 call for holiness. John 13:34-35 gives the new commandment. 2 Thessalonians 3:6-13 deals with idleness. Matthew 24:42-44 compares the coming to a thief. Ephesians 6:13-17 describes the armor. Philippians 4:4-7 is a parallel on joy and prayer. Luke 18:1 and Colossians 4:2 speak of constant prayer. 1 John 4:1 says to test the spirits. Hebrews 13:7, 17 speak of leaders. Philippians 1:6 and Jude 24 assure of God’s keeping.

STEP 6

Application

Pick one of the short commands in 5:14-22 and practice it today.

Practice thanks in all circumstances: list three things for which to give thanks right now, even in hard times.

Ask what “quiet” work you can do faithfully, and do it as for the Lord.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to sanctify you completely and keep you blameless.
- Ask him to help you encourage someone with the hope of his coming.
- Tell him what you want to hold on to as you wait.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 115

“And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him.”

COLOSSIANS 3:17

DAY 805 · WEEK 115

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Colossians 3:17 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."

COLOSSIANS 3:17

REST

Meditation

This verse is a summary of a whole way of life.

"And whatever you do." The scope is total. Not just the religious parts of life, but everything. Eating, working, speaking, parenting, driving, resting.

"In word or deed." Our speech and our actions both. Together they make up the whole of what we show the world.

"Do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus." To act in someone's name is to act on his authority and on his behalf. A Christian is an ambassador. We represent Christ in every place. We ask: Would he put his name on this? Does this honor him?

"Giving thanks to God the Father through him." The attitude is gratitude. Everything we have comes from the Father through the Son. Thanksgiving turns ordinary tasks into worship.

This verse removes the divide between sacred and secular. A meal can be a prayer, a job can be worship, a conversation can be ministry.

When your day feels ordinary or scattered, say this verse. Offer it all in his name, with thanks.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished Colossians and read 1 Thessalonians. Colossians 2 and 3 warned against empty philosophy and human tradition and taught that the old covenant regulations were a shadow whose substance is Christ. Because we have been raised with Christ, we seek the things above, put off the old self, put on compassion, kindness, humility, and love, and let the word of Christ dwell in us richly. Chapter 3 and 4 applied this to households, work, prayer, and speech. A doctrinal pause considered ordinary work as service to the Lord Christ. First Thessalonians presented a model church that turned from idols to serve the living God and wait for his Son, a pastor's tender heart, comfort for those who grieve, and a series of final commands: rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances. A doctrinal pause on the return of Christ affirmed that he will come again to raise the dead and gather his people.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Colossians 3:23 says to work heartily, as for the Lord and not for men. What task in your week do you do half-heartedly? How might you do it differently if you remembered who your real Master is?

Paul told the Thessalonians not to grieve as those who have no hope. Who is someone you could comfort with the hope of Christ's return and the resurrection? What will you say or do?

First Thessalonians 5:16-18 gives three short commands: rejoice, pray, give thanks. Which is hardest for you right now? What might help you practice it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Offer what you do this week to God, giving thanks to the Father through Jesus.

Thank him that Christ is coming.

Rest in his faithfulness.

DAY 806 · WEEK 116

Psalm 27

I believe I shall look upon the goodness of the LORD

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 27. It is a psalm of David that begins with confidence and moves into a plea. Notice the one thing David asks for, and how the psalm ends with an exhortation to wait.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 27 is a psalm of David, probably from a time of danger from enemies. It has two parts: verses 1 to 6 are a song of trust, and verses 7 to 14 are a prayer for help. It fits our reading in 1 Thessalonians, where believers faced persecution, and in the Prison Epistles, where Paul writes from chains. The psalm teaches us that confidence in God and honest prayer belong together.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “The LORD is my light and my salvation; whom shall I fear?” (v. 1).
2. “Though an army encamp against me, my heart shall not fear” (v. 3).
3. “One thing have I asked of the LORD, that will I seek after: that I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life” (v. 4).
4. “To gaze upon the beauty of the LORD and to inquire in his temple” (v. 4).
5. “For he will hide me in his shelter in the day of trouble” (v. 5).
6. “You have said, Seek my face. My heart says to you, Your face, LORD, do I seek” (v. 8).
7. “For my father and my mother have forsaken me, but the LORD will take me in” (v. 10).
8. “I believe that I shall look upon the goodness of the LORD in the land of the living!” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David begins with three titles for God: light, salvation, and stronghold. “The LORD is my light and my salvation; whom shall I fear? The LORD is the stronghold of my life; of whom shall I be afraid?” Light dispels darkness, salvation rescues, stronghold protects. When evildoers assail him to eat up his flesh, they stumble and fall. “Though an army encamp against me, my heart shall not fear; though war arise against me, yet I will be confident.” The confidence is not in himself but in the LORD.

Then the heart of the psalm: “One thing have I asked of the LORD, that will I seek after: that I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life, to gaze upon the beauty of the LORD and to inquire in his temple.” Of all that he could ask, David asks for one thing: God’s presence. This is the great desire of the believer. In the temple, he gazes on the beauty of the LORD. The dwelling place of God is the source of safety: “For he will hide me in his shelter in the day of trouble; he will conceal me under the cover of his tent; he will lift me high upon a rock.” The result is joy: “I will offer in his tent sacrifices with shouts of joy; I will sing and make melody to the LORD.”

The second half is a prayer. “Hear, O LORD, when I cry aloud; be gracious to me and answer me!” David recalls God’s call: “You have said, Seek my face. My heart says to you, Your face, LORD, do I seek. Hide not your face from me.” The invitation to seek God’s face is God’s own. We pray because he invited us. Even if his parents forsake him, which is a deep fear, “the LORD will take me in.” God is a better father than any earthly one. He asks to be taught God’s way and led on a level path, because of his enemies, who breathe violence.

The psalm ends with a statement of faith and an exhortation. “I believe that I shall look upon the goodness of the LORD in the land of the living!” The believer expects to see the goodness of God now, not only in the age to come. And then David turns to us: “Wait for the LORD; be strong, and let your heart take courage; wait for the LORD!” Waiting is the posture of trust. In Christ, our greatest desire is met. He is the true temple, where God dwells with us. He is the light of the world. The beauty of the LORD is seen “in the face of Jesus Christ” (2 Corinthians 4:6).

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 84:1-4 also speaks of longing for God’s dwelling. Psalm 63:1-3 and 42:1-2 speak of thirst for God. John 1:14 and 8:12 present Christ as the dwelling and the light. 2 Corinthians 4:6 speaks of seeing God’s glory in Christ’s face. Isaiah 49:15 speaks of God’s care exceeding a

mother's. Isaiah 40:31 promises renewal to those who wait. Romans 8:31-39 assures us that nothing can separate us from God's love. Hebrews 10:19-22 invites us into God's presence. Revelation 21:22-23 pictures God as the temple and Lamb as the light.

STEP 6

Application

Ask the question: if I could ask for one thing from God, what would it be? Let it be to know him.

Take five minutes to gaze on the beauty of the LORD: read a passage about Christ and meditate on his character.

Wait for the LORD today in a specific matter, and ask him to strengthen your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you fear, and say, "The LORD is my light and salvation."

Ask him for the one thing: to dwell with him and see his beauty.

Wait for him and take courage.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 116

"Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you."

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

DAY 807 · WEEK 116

Psalm 138

I give you thanks with my whole heart

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 138. David gives thanks with his whole heart. Notice that his praise is directed to the LORD before other gods, and that it is based on God's steadfast love, his faithfulness, and his answer to prayer.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 138 begins a final group of psalms by David (138 to 145). It is a thanksgiving psalm, offered in response to an answered prayer. David praises God "before the gods," that is, in the presence of the pagan powers and idols, and expects that all the kings of the earth will join. It echoes the Prison Epistles' theme that Christ is exalted above all powers.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I give you thanks, O LORD, with my whole heart; before the gods I sing your praise" (v. 1).
2. "For you have exalted above all things your name and your word" (v. 2).
3. "On the day I called, you answered me; my strength of soul you increased" (v. 3).
4. "All the kings of the earth shall give you thanks, O LORD" (v. 4).
5. "For though the LORD is high, he regards the lowly" (v. 6).
6. "Though I walk in the midst of trouble, you preserve my life" (v. 7).
7. "The LORD will fulfill his purpose for me; your steadfast love, O LORD, endures forever" (v. 8).
8. "Do not forsake the work of your hands" (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with wholehearted praise. David refuses to give thanks halfway. He sings "before the gods," which probably refers to the gods of the nations or the heavenly powers. Even in the presence of rivals, he praises the LORD. He bows toward the holy temple and gives thanks to God's name "for your steadfast love and your faithfulness, for you have exalted above all things your name and your word." God's name is his revealed character, and his word is his promise. Both are supremely reliable.

Verse 3 is a testimony: "On the day I called, you answered me; my strength of soul you increased." The answer was not necessarily the removal of trouble but strength within it. The effect of God's answer extends outward: "All the kings of the earth shall give you thanks, O LORD, for they have heard the words of your mouth, and they shall sing of the ways of the LORD, for great is the glory of the LORD." David's experience of God's faithfulness is a testimony to the nations. This is a missionary note. One day, kings will sing the praises of the LORD.

Verse 6 holds a great truth: "For though the LORD is high, he regards the lowly, but the haughty he knows from afar." God is exalted, and yet he looks on the humble. The proud cannot approach him. This is the theme of the Christ hymn in Philippians 2. The one who humbled himself is now exalted, and God looks on those who humble themselves.

David then expresses trust in future danger: "Though I walk in the midst of trouble, you preserve my life; you stretch out your hand against the wrath of my enemies, and your right hand delivers me." The key promise is verse 8: "The LORD will fulfill his purpose for me." This echoes Philippians 1:6: he who began a good work will bring it to completion. God's purposes for us cannot be thwarted. Based on God's steadfast love that endures forever, David prays, "Do not forsake the work of your hands." It is a prayer of confidence, not doubt: because God has made us and begun a work in us, we ask him to finish it.

STEP 5

Connection

Philippians 1:6 and Psalm 57:2 speak of God fulfilling his purpose. Psalm 100 and 136 emphasize steadfast love. Psalm 72:11 and 102:15 speak of kings worshiping. Isaiah 57:15 says God dwells with the contrite and lowly. James 4:6 and 1 Peter 5:5 say God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble. Luke 1:48-52 is Mary's song of the lowly lifted. Jeremiah 29:11 speaks of God's plans. Revelation 21:24-26 pictures kings bringing glory into the city. Ephesians 2:10 speaks of us as God's workmanship.

STEP 6

Application

Give thanks to God today with your whole heart, with no reservations.

Recall a day you called and he answered. Tell it to someone.

Pray verse 8 over a project or relationship: LORD, fulfill your purpose here.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give God thanks with your whole heart, naming something.

Thank him that he exalted his word above his name.

Ask him to complete what he has begun in you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 116

"Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you."

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

DAY 808 · WEEK 116

Psalm 139:13-24

You formed my inward parts

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 139:13-24. You may have read the first half before. Read this section on God's formation of us in the womb and the prayer to be searched and led. Notice how awe and honest self-examination fit together.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 139 is one of the most intimate psalms, celebrating God's knowledge, presence, and creative care. The first twelve verses describe how God knows us completely and is present everywhere. Verses 13 to 18 describe how God made us. Verses 19 to 22 are an outburst against the wicked. Verses 23 and 24 are a closing prayer for God to search the speaker's own heart. It connects with the Prison Epistles' emphasis that we are God's workmanship, known and led by him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For you formed my inward parts; you knitted me together in my mother's womb" (v. 13).
2. "I praise you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made" (v. 14).
3. "My frame was not hidden from you, when I was being made in secret" (v. 15).
4. "In your book were written, every one of them, the days that were formed for me, when as yet there was none of them" (v. 16).
5. "How precious to me are your thoughts, O God! How vast is the sum of them!" (v. 17).
6. "If I would count them, they are more than the sand" (v. 18).
7. "Search me, O God, and know my heart! Try me and know my thoughts!" (v. 23).

8 “And lead me in the way everlasting!” (v. 24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David marvels at his own creation. “For you formed my inward parts; you knitted me together in my mother’s womb.” God is a weaver and an artist. “I praise you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Wonderful are your works; my soul knows it very well.” The human being is a marvel of design, and knowing this produces praise. This psalm is often cited for the dignity of life before birth. The Bible regards the unborn as persons known and formed by God. Every human life is intentionally made.

“My frame was not hidden from you, when I was being made in secret, intricately woven in the depths of the earth.” The “depths of the earth” is a poetic image for the womb, an echo of Adam’s formation from the earth. “Your eyes saw my unformed substance; in your book were written, every one of them, the days that were formed for me, when as yet there was none of them.” God’s knowledge extends to our days before we have lived them. This is not a statement of fatalism but of providence. Every day belongs to God.

The reaction: “How precious to me are your thoughts, O God! How vast is the sum of them! If I would count them, they are more than the sand. I awake, and I am still with you.” Dazed by God’s greatness, David finds himself still in God’s presence. Verses 19 to 22 give a strong expression of hatred of God’s enemies: “Do you not hate those who hate you, O LORD?” This sounds jarring, but David’s motive is zeal for God, not private spite. Christians read this in light of Jesus’ command to love our enemies. We hate sin and pray for sinners.

Then the psalm turns from the enemies to himself. “Search me, O God, and know my heart! Try me and know my thoughts! And see if there be any grievous way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting!” After praising God’s knowledge of him, David invites that knowledge to examine him. He does not fear being exposed because he trusts the one who exposes. He wants to be corrected. “The way everlasting” is the way that leads to life, the path of faithfulness. This is a good prayer for each morning.

In Christ, this prayer is safe. Christ knows our sins and yet bore them. He is the way everlasting (John 14:6). The one who searches us is the one who loves us.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 1:5 says God knew the prophet before forming him in the womb. Job 10:8-12 and Psalm 119:73 also speak of God’s making. Ecclesiastes 11:5 compares the mystery of the womb to God’s works. Luke 1:39-45 mentions John leaping in the womb. Psalm 51:6 and

Hebrews 4:12-13 speak of God's searching knowledge. Psalm 19:12-14 prays for cleansing from hidden faults. Romans 8:29 and Ephesians 1:4 speak of God's knowledge before creation. John 14:6 says Jesus is the way. Matthew 5:43-48 teaches love of enemies.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God today for how you were made. Name something about yourself you've struggled to accept.

Pray verses 23 and 24 at the start of the day, and be ready for the answer.

Treat every person you meet as someone fearfully and wonderfully made, including the unborn and the elderly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that you are fearfully and wonderfully made.
- Ask him to search your heart and lead you in the everlasting way.
- Tell him what anxious thoughts you want him to know.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 116

"Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you."

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

DAY 809 · WEEK 116

2 Thessalonians 1:1-3:18

The man of lawlessness; stand firm; work while you wait

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Thessalonians 1:1-3:18. This short letter was written soon after the first. Read it for its three movements: encouragement in persecution (chapter 1), correction about the day of the Lord (chapter 2), and instruction about idleness (chapter 3).

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

A few months after the first letter, Paul learned that the Thessalonians were still suffering and had become confused about the day of the Lord. Someone had claimed, perhaps in a letter allegedly from Paul, that the day of the Lord had already come. Some stopped working, expecting Christ at any moment. Paul writes to comfort the persecuted, correct the misunderstanding, and tell the idle to work.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “To grant relief to you who are afflicted as well as to us, when the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven with his mighty angels” (1:7).
2. “Let no one deceive you in any way. For that day will not come, unless the rebellion comes first, and the man of lawlessness is revealed” (2:3).
3. “And then the lawless one will be revealed, whom the Lord Jesus will kill with the breath of his mouth” (2:8).
4. “Because God chose you as the firstfruits to be saved, through sanctification by the Spirit and belief in the truth” (2:13).
5. “So then, brothers, stand firm and hold to the traditions that you were taught by us” (2:15).

6. “But the Lord is faithful. He will establish you and guard you against the evil one” (3:3).
7. “If anyone is not willing to work, let him not eat” (3:10).
8. “As for you, brothers, do not grow weary in doing good” (3:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In chapter 1, Paul thanks God for their growing faith and love and boasts of their steadfastness in persecution. Their suffering is “evidence of the righteous judgment of God, that you may be considered worthy of the kingdom of God.” God will repay with affliction those who afflict them and grant relief to the afflicted “when the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven with his mighty angels in flaming fire.” Justice will be done. Paul prays that God would make them worthy of his calling, that the name of Jesus may be glorified in them.

Chapter 2 is among the most debated passages in the New Testament. Paul urges them not to be shaken by claims that the day of the Lord has come. “Let no one deceive you in any way. For that day will not come, unless the rebellion comes first, and the man of lawlessness is revealed, the son of destruction, who opposes and exalts himself against every so-called god or object of worship, so that he takes his seat in the temple of God, proclaiming himself to be God.” Something restrains him, and when the restrainer is removed, the lawless one will be revealed. The Lord Jesus will kill him “with the breath of his mouth and bring to nothing by the appearance of his coming.” His coming will be by the activity of Satan with false signs and wonders, deceiving those who are perishing because they refused to love the truth. Interpreters differ on who the man of lawlessness is: a future individual Antichrist, an institution, a series of persecuting powers (such as Rome or later empires), or a spirit of rebellion embodied in many figures. The restrainer is also variously identified as the Roman Empire, government, the Holy Spirit, or the preaching of the gospel. The key point is clear: Christ will triumph, and believers should not be frightened.

Paul then returns to thanksgiving: “God chose you as the firstfruits to be saved, through sanctification by the Spirit and belief in the truth.” He urges them to stand firm and hold to the traditions they were taught. A prayer: “May our Lord Jesus Christ himself and God our Father, who loved us and gave us eternal comfort and good hope through grace, comfort your hearts and establish them in every good work and word.”

Chapter 3 asks for prayer that the word of the Lord may speed ahead and be honored, and that they may be delivered from wicked and evil people. “But the Lord is faithful. He will establish you and guard you against the evil one.” Then the discipline of idleness. Some were living in idleness, mere busybodies. Paul reminds them of his own example: they worked night and day so as not to burden anyone. “If anyone is not willing to work, let him not eat.” This does not apply to those unable to work, but to those unwilling. He commands them to

work quietly and earn their own living. “As for you, brothers, do not grow weary in doing good.” The letter ends with a benediction of peace and grace, and Paul’s signature as a mark of authenticity.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 7:25, 9:27, 11:36-37 stand behind the man of lawlessness. Matthew 24:15-28 and 1 John 2:18-22 speak of antichrists. Revelation 13 and 19:19-21 describe the beast and Christ’s victory. Isaiah 11:4 speaks of slaying the wicked with the breath of his lips. 1 Thessalonians 4:11 and 5:14 also address idleness. Ephesians 4:28 and Proverbs 6:6-11 speak of work. Galatians 6:9 repeats the encouragement not to grow weary. John 17:15 prays that God would keep us from the evil one.

STEP 6

Application

If you are suffering for your faith or for doing right, take comfort in 1:5-7. God sees.

Ask if you are tempted to idleness or to being a busybody. What is one productive thing you can do today?

Memorize 3:3 as a promise: the Lord is faithful; he will establish and guard you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that he will be revealed from heaven and bring justice.
- Ask him to help you stand firm and not be shaken.
- Ask him to give you strength to keep working while you wait.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 116

“Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you.”

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

DAY 810 · WEEK 116

1 Timothy 1:1-3:16

Sound doctrine; prayer; overseers and deacons

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 49 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Timothy 1:1-3:16. Paul writes to his younger coworker Timothy, who is leading the church in Ephesus. Notice the concern for sound doctrine, the priority of prayer, and the qualifications for overseers and deacons. Read slowly through 3:1-13 and 3:14-16.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, and Titus are called the Pastoral Epistles because they were written to pastors, Timothy and Titus, for the care of churches. Paul probably wrote 1 Timothy around AD 62 to 64, after his first Roman imprisonment, to Timothy in Ephesus. False teachers were spreading myths and speculations. Paul instructs Timothy on doctrine, worship, leadership, and conduct in "the household of God, which is the church of the living God."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The aim of our charge is love that issues from a pure heart and a good conscience and a sincere faith" (1:5).
2. "The saying is trustworthy and deserving of full acceptance, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the foremost" (1:15).
3. "Who desires all people to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth" (2:4).
4. "For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus" (2:5).
5. "The saying is trustworthy: If anyone aspires to the office of overseer, he desires a noble task" (3:1).

6. “Therefore an overseer must be above reproach” (3:2).
7. “The household of God, which is the church of the living God, a pillar and buttress of the truth” (3:15).
8. “Great indeed, we confess, is the mystery of godliness” (3:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul tells Timothy to charge certain persons not to teach different doctrine, nor to devote themselves to myths and endless genealogies, which promote speculations rather than the stewardship from God that is by faith. “The aim of our charge is love that issues from a pure heart and a good conscience and a sincere faith.” Some have wandered away into vain discussion, desiring to be teachers of the law without understanding. The law is good if one uses it lawfully, as pointing out sin. Then Paul gives his testimony: formerly a blasphemer, persecutor, and insolent opponent, he received mercy because he had acted ignorantly in unbelief. “The saying is trustworthy and deserving of full acceptance, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the foremost.” “Foremost” (or chief) is present tense: Paul still sees himself as the chief of sinners. And he received mercy so that Christ might display his perfect patience as an example. A doxology follows: “To the King of the ages, immortal, invisible, the only God, be honor and glory forever and ever.”

In chapter 2, Paul gives priority to prayer: “First of all, then, I urge that supplications, prayers, intercessions, and thanksgivings be made for all people, for kings and all who are in high positions, that we may lead a peaceful and quiet life, godly and dignified in every way.” This is pleasing to God our Savior, “who desires all people to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth. For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a ransom for all.” The gospel is for all kinds of people, and there is only one way. The rest of chapter 2 includes instructions for men and women in worship, including verses 11 to 15 on women teaching, which have been interpreted in different ways. Some hold that Paul restricts the office of elder/teacher to men; others hold that the instruction was shaped by the Ephesian situation, with false teaching among some women; many hold that the passage should be read with attention to the creation reference in verses 13 and 14. Christians who honor Scripture land in different places, so a charitable spirit is called for.

Chapter 3 gives the qualifications for overseers (also called elders or pastors) and deacons. “If anyone aspires to the office of overseer, he desires a noble task.” The list is mostly about character: above reproach, the husband of one wife, sober-minded, self-controlled, respectable, hospitable, able to teach, not a drunkard, not violent but gentle, not quarrelsome, not a lover of money, managing his household well, not a recent convert, well

thought of by outsiders. Only “able to teach” is a skill. Deacons likewise must be dignified, hold the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience, be tested, and be faithful. We examine this more on Day 811.

The section ends with the purpose: “I am writing these things to you so that, if I delay, you may know how one ought to behave in the household of God, which is the church of the living God, a pillar and buttress of the truth.” And a hymn: “Great indeed, we confess, is the mystery of godliness: He was manifested in the flesh, vindicated by the Spirit, seen by angels, proclaimed among the nations, believed on in the world, taken up in glory.” The center of church life is Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 20:17-38 records Paul’s farewell to the Ephesian elders. Romans 3:19-20 and 7:12 speak of the use of the law. Acts 9:1-19 tells of Paul’s conversion. Ephesians 2:19-22 describes the household of God. Titus 1:5-9 gives parallel qualifications. Acts 6:1-6 describes the first servants. Philippians 1:1 mentions overseers and deacons. 1 Peter 5:1-4 is Peter’s charge to elders. Hebrews 8:6 and 9:15 speak of the mediator. Philippians 2:5-11 is another early hymn.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for the leaders of the world and of your community by name, as verse 2:1-2 commands.

Pray for the pastors and elders of your church as you read 3:1-7. Which quality do you see in them?

Memorize 1:15 and say it to yourself when you are tempted to think you are too far gone or too good to need grace.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for coming to save sinners and for his mercy to you.

Ask him to help you fight the good fight with a good conscience.

Pray for those in authority and the people around you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 116

“Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you.”

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

DAY 811 · WEEK 116

1 Timothy 3:1-13; Titus 1:5-9; Acts 6:1-6

Church Government and Officers

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Timothy 3:1-13, Titus 1:5-9, and Acts 6:1-6. Today is a doctrinal pause on church government and officers. Notice the qualifications for elders and deacons and how the first servants were appointed.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

How should a church be organized and led? The New Testament does not give a detailed blueprint, but it does describe the roles of elders (also called overseers or pastors) and deacons, and it describes how the early churches appointed them. Christians have drawn different conclusions about the best form of church government, but there is wide agreement about the character and function of the leaders.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “If anyone aspires to the office of overseer, he desires a noble task” (1 Timothy 3:1).
2. “Able to teach” (1 Timothy 3:2).
3. “Deacons likewise must be dignified, not double-tongued, not addicted to much wine, not greedy for dishonest gain” (1 Timothy 3:8).
4. “For those who serve well as deacons gain a good standing for themselves and also great confidence in the faith that is in Christ Jesus” (1 Timothy 3:13).
5. “This is why I left you in Crete, so that you might put what remained into order, and appoint elders in every town as I directed you” (Titus 1:5).

6 “He must hold firm to the trustworthy word as taught, so that he may be able to give instruction in sound doctrine and also to rebuke those who contradict it” (Titus 1:9).

7 “Therefore, brothers, pick out from among you seven men of good repute, full of the Spirit and of wisdom, whom we will appoint to this duty” (Acts 6:3).

8 “But we will devote ourselves to prayer and to the ministry of the word” (Acts 6:4).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The New Testament speaks of two ongoing offices in the local church: elders (presbyteroi), also called overseers (episkopoi) and shepherds or pastors (poimenes), and deacons (diakonoi). Elders lead, teach, and shepherd the flock. Deacons serve, particularly in practical and material needs. The apostles were a unique foundational office, which has not continued.

Elders and overseers appear to be the same office, since Paul uses the terms interchangeably in Titus 1:5-7 and Acts 20:17, 28. Their qualifications emphasize character: above reproach, faithful to their spouse, self-controlled, hospitable, gentle, not greedy, managing their household well. Their tasks are to teach, shepherd, guard the flock from false teaching, and lead. The only ability required is to teach. In Acts 20:28, Paul tells the Ephesian elders to “care for the church of God, which he obtained with his own blood.”

Deacons came from the appointment of the seven in Acts 6, so that the apostles could devote themselves to prayer and the ministry of the word, while others cared for widows’ food. The seven were “men of good repute, full of the Spirit and of wisdom.” Deacons serve the church’s practical needs and free the elders to lead and teach. Romans 16:1 calls Phoebe a deacon (or servant) of the church at Cenchreae. Christians differ on whether women may serve as deacons: some read 1 Timothy 3:11 as referring to women deacons, others to the wives of deacons.

Churches organize themselves in different ways. The episcopal model (Roman Catholic, Orthodox, Anglican, Methodist) has bishops who oversee multiple congregations. The presbyterian model has elders who govern the church and regional bodies of elders (presbyteries and assemblies). The congregational model (Baptist and many independent churches) holds that the local congregation is the final earthly authority, led by elders and deacons. Disagreements remain over the role of the congregation, the relationship between local churches, and who may hold office, including whether women may be elders. These are important matters, and we should study them in humility.

Agreed principles: leaders are servants, not lords (1 Peter 5:3; Mark 10:42-45). Their authority comes from Scripture. They are accountable to Christ, the chief shepherd, and to the church. The congregation should respect and follow godly leaders (Hebrews 13:17), while testing everything by the word.

STEP 4

Interpretation

1 Timothy 3:1 says that aspiring to the office of overseer is a noble desire. But the emphasis is on character. “Above reproach” means no charge can be brought against his life. “The husband of one wife” is generally understood as faithful to his wife, though Christians differ on whether it excludes divorced and remarried men, singles, or women. “Sober-minded, self-controlled, respectable, hospitable, able to teach, not a drunkard, not violent but gentle, not quarrelsome, not a lover of money. He must manage his own household well, with all dignity keeping his children submissive, for if someone does not know how to manage his own household, how will he care for God’s church? He must not be a recent convert, or he may become puffed up with conceit. Moreover, he must be well thought of by outsiders.” The home is the proving ground.

Deacons likewise must be dignified. They must hold the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience. They are to be tested first, and then let them serve if they prove themselves blameless. “For those who serve well as deacons gain a good standing for themselves and also great confidence in the faith that is in Christ Jesus.”

In Titus 1, Paul left Titus in Crete to appoint elders in every town. The qualifications are similar. The elder, as God’s steward, must be above reproach, not arrogant or quick-tempered, a lover of good, self-controlled, upright, holy. “He must hold firm to the trustworthy word as taught, so that he may be able to give instruction in sound doctrine and also to rebuke those who contradict it.” The elder both builds up and guards.

Acts 6 shows how the first church solved a problem. The Hellenist widows were being neglected in the daily distribution. The Twelve said, “It is not right that we should give up preaching the word of God to serve tables.” They asked the church to pick out seven men of good repute, full of the Spirit and wisdom. The church chose, the apostles prayed and laid hands on them, “and the word of God continued to increase.” Notice the shape: leaders delegate; the congregation participates; the priority is the word and prayer; the result is growth.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 14:23 and 20:17-38 describe the appointment of elders. 1 Peter 5:1-5 gives Peter's charge to elders. Hebrews 13:7, 17 speak of respecting leaders. Philippians 1:1 greets overseers and deacons. Romans 16:1-2 mentions Phoebe. Ephesians 4:11-12 speaks of shepherds and teachers equipping the saints. 3 John 9-10 warns of a domineering leader. Mark 10:42-45 contrasts Jesus' model of leadership with the world's. 1 Corinthians 12:28 lists gifts of administration and helping. Matthew 20:25-28 echoes the servant principle.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for your elders and deacons by name. Thank at least one for something specific.

If God is leading you to aspire to serve as a leader, ask a pastor to help you test it by these qualifications.

Find a practical need in your church and meet it, as the seven did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus, the Chief Shepherd, for the leaders he has given his church.

Pray for your own church leaders by name.

Ask him to help you follow and support them.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 116

"Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you."

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

DAY 812 · WEEK 116

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Thessalonians 5:16-18 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you."

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

REST

Meditation

These three short commands are among the simplest and most challenging in the Bible.

"Rejoice always." Joy that does not depend on circumstances is possible because its source is the Lord. Paul is not asking us to feel happy about suffering but to rejoice in God's presence, promises, and salvation. Even tears and joy can coexist.

"Pray without ceasing." This does not mean we stay on our knees all day, but that we live in constant awareness of God, turning to him in short prayers throughout the day and setting aside times for deeper prayer. It is a posture of dependence.

"Give thanks in all circumstances." Not for all circumstances, but in them. We can thank God in the midst of loss because he is with us and working. Gratitude changes our outlook.

“For this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you.” Many people wonder about God’s will. Here is a clear answer: joy, prayer, and thanksgiving. And it is “in Christ Jesus”: the power to do it comes from him.

When your day becomes anxious, say this verse and take one of these three steps right then.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the end of 1 Thessalonians, with its call to holy living, the day of the Lord, and short commands to rejoice, pray, and give thanks. Three psalms taught confidence and wonder: Psalm 27, one thing I ask, to dwell in the house of the LORD and gaze upon his beauty; Psalm 138, I give you thanks with my whole heart, and the LORD will fulfill his purpose for me; and Psalm 139, I am fearfully and wonderfully made, search me and lead me in the way everlasting. Second Thessalonians comforted the persecuted, warned against being shaken by claims about the day of the Lord, and called the idle to work. First Timothy began the Pastoral Epistles with sound doctrine, prayer for all people, the one mediator, and the qualifications of overseers and deacons. A doctrinal pause considered church government and officers: elders who shepherd and teach, deacons who serve, and a congregation that follows godly leaders.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Psalm 27 says the one thing David asked for was to dwell in the house of the LORD and gaze on his beauty. What would you say is the one thing you most seek? How could you ask God to make knowing him your deepest desire?

Second Thessalonians says, “The Lord is faithful. He will establish you and guard you against the evil one.” What threat or fear in your life do you need to entrust to God’s faithfulness?

Paul gives Timothy a list of character qualities for church leaders, mostly about integrity and home life. Which of these do you most want to grow in, whether or not you’re a leader? What is one step?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the call to rejoice, pray, and give thanks.

Tell him what you have to give thanks for in your circumstances.

Rest in him.

DAY 813 · WEEK 117

1 Timothy 4:1-6:21

Godliness; widows and elders; the good fight

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 69 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Timothy 4:1-6:21. Paul gives Timothy instruction on guarding against false teaching, on his own example and ministry, on caring for various groups in the church, and on the dangers of money. Notice how often Paul turns from doctrine to daily conduct.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul continues his letter to Timothy in Ephesus. False teachers were forbidding marriage and certain foods, and others were using religion for profit. Timothy was young and perhaps timid. Paul encourages him to be an example, to devote himself to public reading of Scripture, and to fight the good fight of faith. The letter also gives guidance for widows, elders, slaves and masters, and the rich.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “For everything created by God is good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving” (4:4).
2. “For while bodily training is of some value, godliness is of value in every way” (4:8).
3. “Let no one despise you for your youth, but set the believers an example in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, in purity” (4:12).
4. “Devote yourself to the public reading of Scripture, to exhortation, to teaching” (4:13).
5. “Keep a close watch on yourself and on the teaching. Persist in this, for by so doing you will save both yourself and your hearers” (4:16).
6. “But godliness with contentment is great gain” (6:6).

7. “For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evils” (6:10).
8. “Fight the good fight of the faith. Take hold of the eternal life to which you were called” (6:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 4 opens with a warning that in later times some will depart from the faith, devoting themselves to deceitful spirits and teachings of demons. They forbid marriage and require abstinence from foods. Paul answers with creation: “For everything created by God is good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving, for it is made holy by the word of God and prayer.” Marriage and food are gifts. Christians are free to enjoy them with gratitude, though not to worship them.

Timothy is to be a good servant of Christ Jesus, nourished on the words of the faith. He is to have nothing to do with irreverent myths and to train himself for godliness. “For while bodily training is of some value, godliness is of value in every way, as it holds promise for the present life and also for the life to come.” Exercise is good, but spiritual discipline matters more and lasts. “Let no one despise you for your youth, but set the believers an example in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, in purity.” Authority comes from example. Until Paul arrives, Timothy is to give attention to Scripture reading, exhortation, and teaching, and not to neglect the gift given to him when the elders laid their hands on him. “Keep a close watch on yourself and on the teaching.” A pastor must watch both his life and his doctrine.

Chapter 5 gives practical guidance. Treat older men as fathers, younger men as brothers, older women as mothers, younger women as sisters, in all purity. Care for widows who are truly in need, and let families care for their own: “If anyone does not provide for his relatives, and especially for members of his household, he has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever.” Elders who rule well are worthy of double honor, especially those who labor in preaching and teaching, and the worker deserves his wages. Accusations against an elder require two or three witnesses, and those who persist in sin are to be rebuked publicly. Timothy is to keep these rules without prejudice or partiality, to be careful about laying on hands hastily, and to keep himself pure. Paul adds a small word about his health: “No longer drink only water, but use a little wine for the sake of your stomach and your frequent ailments.”

Chapter 6 speaks to slaves and masters, and to false teachers who suppose that godliness is a means of gain. “But godliness with contentment is great gain, for we brought nothing into the world, and we cannot take anything out of the world.” Those who desire to be rich fall into temptation. “For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evils. It is through this craving that some have wandered away from the faith and pierced themselves with many pangs.”

Note that it is the love of money, not money itself. Timothy is to flee these things and pursue righteousness, godliness, faith, love, steadfastness, gentleness. “Fight the good fight of the faith. Take hold of the eternal life to which you were called.” The rich are to be generous and rich in good works, storing up treasure as a good foundation for the future. The letter ends with a plea: “O Timothy, guard the deposit entrusted to you.”

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:31 and Mark 7:19 affirm the goodness of creation and food. Hebrews 13:4 honors marriage. Acts 16:1-3 introduces Timothy. 2 Timothy 1:6 mentions his gift. Deuteronomy 25:4 and Luke 10:7 are behind the wage principle. Philippians 4:11-13 speaks of contentment. Matthew 6:19-24 teaches that we cannot serve God and money. Hebrews 13:5 says to be content with what you have. Ecclesiastes 5:10 warns about loving money. Jude 3 speaks of contending for the faith.

STEP 6

Application

Receive your next meal and a gift in your life with thanksgiving, and say the prayer aloud.

Ask which area of your life (speech, conduct, love, faith, purity) most needs to be an example, and take one step.

Examine your relationship with money. Ask: what do I love? Plan one generous gift this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Receive God’s gifts with thanksgiving, and name some.
- Ask him to train you for godliness.
- Ask him to help you fight the good fight of faith.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 117

“All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work.”

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17

DAY 814 · WEEK 117

2 Timothy 1:1-2:26

Guard the deposit; rightly handling the word

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Timothy 1:1-2:26. This is Paul's last letter, written from prison with death near. Notice the tenderness toward Timothy, the call to guard the gospel, and the pictures of the faithful servant: soldier, athlete, farmer, worker.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Second Timothy was written around AD 66 to 67, during Paul's second imprisonment in Rome, probably shortly before his execution. Unlike his first imprisonment, this one is harsh, and Paul is alone except for Luke. He writes to Timothy, his beloved child in the faith, to strengthen him to carry on, to guard the gospel, and to be willing to suffer. It is a farewell letter and a passing of the torch.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For God gave us a spirit not of fear but of power and love and self-control" (1:7).
2. "Who saved us and called us to a holy calling, not because of our works but because of his own purpose and grace" (1:9).
3. "For I know whom I have believed, and I am convinced that he is able to guard until that day what has been entrusted to me" (1:12).
4. "By the Holy Spirit who dwells within us, guard the good deposit entrusted to you" (1:14).
5. "And what you have heard from me in the presence of many witnesses entrust to faithful men, who will be able to teach others also" (2:2).
6. "Share in suffering as a good soldier of Christ Jesus" (2:3).

7. “Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who has no need to be ashamed, rightly handling the word of truth” (2:15).

8. “The Lord’s servant must not be quarrelsome but kind to everyone, able to teach, patiently enduring evil” (2:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with thanks and longing. He remembers Timothy’s tears, recalls the sincere faith that lived in his grandmother Lois and mother Eunice, and reminds him to fan into flame the gift of God that is in him. “For God gave us a spirit not of fear but of power and love and self-control.” Timothy seems to have been timid. Fear is not from God, and the Spirit gives courage, love, and discipline. “Therefore do not be ashamed of the testimony about our Lord, nor of me his prisoner, but share in suffering for the gospel by the power of God.”

Then a summary of the gospel: God “saved us and called us to a holy calling, not because of our works but because of his own purpose and grace, which he gave us in Christ Jesus before the ages began, and which now has been manifested through the appearing of our Savior Christ Jesus, who abolished death and brought life and immortality to light through the gospel.” Paul is not ashamed, even in a dungeon: “For I know whom I have believed, and I am convinced that he is able to guard until that day what has been entrusted to me.” Faith is knowing a person. Paul urges Timothy to follow the pattern of sound words and to guard the good deposit by the Holy Spirit. Some, like Phygelus and Hermogenes, have turned away. Onesiphorus, however, was not ashamed of Paul’s chains and refreshed him often, and Paul prays mercy on his household.

Chapter 2 builds on the picture of ministry as hard work. Timothy is to be strengthened by the grace in Christ Jesus and to pass on the gospel: “What you have heard from me in the presence of many witnesses entrust to faithful men, who will be able to teach others also.” Four generations appear here: Paul, Timothy, faithful men, and others. Discipleship is multiplication. Then three images: the soldier, who avoids civilian entanglements to please his commander; the athlete, who competes by the rules; the farmer, who works hard before sharing the crops. Each requires single-mindedness, discipline, and patience. “Remember Jesus Christ, risen from the dead, the offspring of David, as preached in my gospel, for which I am suffering, bound with chains. But the word of God is not bound!”

Paul quotes a trustworthy saying: “If we have died with him, we will also live with him; if we endure, we will also reign with him; if we deny him, he also will deny us; if we are faithless, he remains faithful, for he cannot deny himself.” Timothy is to avoid quarrels about words and irreverent babble. “Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who has no need to be ashamed, rightly handling the word of truth.” Some have swerved

from the truth, like Hymenaeus and Philetus, who say the resurrection has already happened. But “God’s firm foundation stands, bearing this seal: The Lord knows those who are his.” The household of God contains vessels for honor and for dishonor; Timothy is to cleanse himself, flee youthful passions, and pursue righteousness, faith, love, and peace. The Lord’s servant must be kind, patient, and gentle in correcting opponents, in the hope that God may grant them repentance.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 16:1-3 introduces Timothy and his mother. 1 Timothy 1:18 and 4:14 refer to his gift. Romans 1:16 says Paul is not ashamed of the gospel. Titus 3:5-7 echoes salvation by mercy and not works. Ephesians 1:4 speaks of grace given before the ages. 1 Corinthians 9:24-27 uses the athlete image. Philippians 2:25 and Philemon 2 use soldier language. Numbers 16:5 is quoted in 2:19. Matthew 28:19-20 gives the mission of making disciples. Romans 6:8 and 8:17 parallel the faithful saying.

STEP 6

Application

Name a fear that holds you back and ask God for his spirit of power, love, and self-control.

Think of the people who passed the faith to you. Write to one to thank them. Then think of who you might pass it to.

Which picture fits you today: soldier, athlete, farmer, or worker? Take one step in that direction.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for giving you a spirit of power, love, and self-control.
- Ask him to help you guard the good deposit.
- Ask him to help you handle his word rightly.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 117

“All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work.”

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17

DAY 815 · WEEK 117

2 Timothy 3:1-4:22

Difficult times; preach the word; finish the race

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 39 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Timothy 3:1-4:22. These are Paul's last recorded words. Notice the warning about hard times, the great statement about Scripture, the solemn charge to preach, and Paul's own testimony as he faces death.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul writes his final instructions to Timothy. He knows his time is short. The church will face difficult days, and false teachers will multiply. His solution is not new methods but the faithful preaching of the word. These verses contain the most important statement in the Bible about the nature of Scripture, and they also give a deeply moving portrait of a servant at the end of his race.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But understand this, that in the last days there will come times of difficulty" (3:1).
2. "Indeed, all who desire to live a godly life in Christ Jesus will be persecuted" (3:12).
3. "And how from childhood you have been acquainted with the sacred writings, which are able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus" (3:15).
4. "All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness" (3:16).
5. "Preach the word; be ready in season and out of season; reprove, rebuke, and exhort, with complete patience and teaching" (4:2).
6. "For the time is coming when people will not endure sound teaching, but having itching ears they will accumulate for themselves teachers to suit their own passions" (4:3).

7. “I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith” (4:7).
8. “But the Lord stood by me and strengthened me, so that through me the message might be fully proclaimed” (4:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul says that “in the last days there will come times of difficulty.” The last days began with Christ’s first coming, so this is a description of the whole era. People will be lovers of self, lovers of money, proud, abusive, disobedient, ungrateful, unholy, heartless, unforgiving, slanderous, without self-control, brutal, haters of good, treacherous, reckless, swollen with conceit, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God, “having the appearance of godliness, but denying its power.” Timothy is to avoid such people. Paul contrasts them with Timothy: “You, however, have followed my teaching, my conduct, my aim in life, my faith, my patience, my love, my steadfastness, my persecutions and sufferings.” Then a sober truth: “Indeed, all who desire to live a godly life in Christ Jesus will be persecuted, while evil people and impostors will go on from bad to worse, deceiving and being deceived.”

Timothy must continue in what he has learned. He knows from whom he learned it and has known “the sacred writings” from childhood, “which are able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus.” Then the great statement: “All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work.” The word “breathed out” (theopneustos) means that Scripture originates in God. It is his word, just as a human’s breath carries his words. It is profitable in four ways: it teaches what is true, reproves what is wrong, corrects the path, and trains in righteousness. And its goal is that we be complete, equipped for every good work. Scripture is sufficient for the life of faith.

Chapter 4 begins with a solemn charge, “in the presence of God and of Christ Jesus, who is to judge the living and the dead.” The command is simple: “Preach the word; be ready in season and out of season; reprove, rebuke, and exhort, with complete patience and teaching.” The reason is that people will turn away. “They will accumulate for themselves teachers to suit their own passions, and will turn away from listening to the truth and wander off into myths.” Timothy is to be sober-minded, endure suffering, do the work of an evangelist, and fulfill his ministry.

Then Paul looks at his own end: “For I am already being poured out as a drink offering, and the time of my departure has come. I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith. Henceforth there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, will award to me on that day, and not only to me but also to all who have loved his appearing.” The letter closes with personal notes: Demas has deserted him,

only Luke is with him, and he asks for Mark, his cloak, and his books and parchments. At his first defense, no one came to stand by him, "but the Lord stood by me and strengthened me." "The Lord will rescue me from every evil deed and bring me safely into his heavenly kingdom. To him be the glory forever and ever. Amen."

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 24:9-13 and 2 Peter 3:3 also warn of hard times. John 15:20 promises persecution. 2 Peter 1:20-21 explains the origin of Scripture. Psalm 19:7-11 and 119:105 praise Scripture's value. Luke 24:44-47 shows Scripture pointing to Christ. Acts 20:24 is Paul's earlier statement about finishing his course. Philippians 2:17 and 1:21-23 also use the drink offering image. 1 Peter 5:4 promises a crown to faithful shepherds. Acts 23:11 and 27:23-24 recall times Christ stood by Paul. Hebrews 4:12 speaks of the living word.

STEP 6

Application

Choose a time and place for reading the Bible every day, and commit to it. Ask God to use Scripture to teach, reprove, correct, and train you.

Let 3:16-17 stay with you.

Ask whether you are finishing well. What is one thing you need to do to keep the faith?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that all Scripture is breathed out by him.
- Ask him to use it to teach, reprove, correct, and train you.
- Ask him to help you finish well.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 117

"All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work."

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17

DAY 816 · WEEK 117

Titus 1:1-3:15

Elders; sound doctrine; good works

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 46 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Titus 1:1-3:15. This short letter to Titus in Crete shows how sound doctrine and good works belong together. Notice the repeated phrases “sound doctrine” and “good works,” and the gospel summaries in 2:11-14 and 3:4-7.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Titus was one of Paul’s trusted coworkers, a Gentile convert. Paul left him on the island of Crete to put the churches in order and appoint elders in every town. The Cretans had a reputation for dishonesty and laziness (even one of their own poets said so), and false teachers were upsetting households. Paul writes to give Titus authority and instructions, and in doing so gives some of the clearest summaries of the gospel in the New Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “They profess to know God, but they deny him by their works” (1:16).
2. “But as for you, teach what accords with sound doctrine” (2:1).
3. “For the grace of God has appeared, bringing salvation for all people” (2:11).
4. “Waiting for our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ” (2:13).
5. “Who gave himself for us to redeem us from all lawlessness and to purify for himself a people for his own possession who are zealous for good works” (2:14).
6. “He saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit” (3:5).

7. “The saying is trustworthy, and I want you to insist on these things, so that those who have believed in God may be careful to devote themselves to good works” (3:8).

8. “But avoid foolish controversies, genealogies, dissensions, and quarrels about the law, for they are unprofitable and worthless” (3:9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul opens with a long greeting that sets the gospel in eternity: he is a servant of God and apostle of Jesus Christ for the sake of the faith of God’s elect and their knowledge of the truth, “in hope of eternal life, which God, who never lies, promised before the ages began.” Then the task: appoint elders (covered on Day 811) and silence the empty talkers who upset whole families. The Cretans, as one of their own prophets said, were “always liars, evil beasts, lazy gluttons.” Titus is to rebuke them sharply that they may be sound in the faith. “To the pure, all things are pure, but to the defiled and unbelieving, nothing is pure; their very minds and consciences are defiled. They profess to know God, but they deny him by their works.”

Chapter 2 gives instruction for each group in the church: older men, older women, younger women, younger men, and slaves. The goal in all cases is to “adorn the doctrine of God our Savior” and keep the word of God from being reviled. Doctrine and life belong together. Then the gospel as the basis for this life: “For the grace of God has appeared, bringing salvation for all people, training us to renounce ungodliness and worldly passions, and to live self-controlled, upright, and godly lives in the present age, waiting for our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ, who gave himself for us to redeem us from all lawlessness and to purify for himself a people for his own possession who are zealous for good works.” Grace does not excuse sin but trains us out of it. Christ is called “our great God and Savior,” one of the plain statements of his deity. He gave himself to redeem and to purify.

In chapter 3, Paul tells Titus to remind believers to be submissive to rulers, to be ready for every good work, to speak evil of no one, and to show perfect courtesy toward all people. Why? Because “we ourselves were once foolish, disobedient, led astray, slaves to various passions and pleasures.” Then the second great summary: “But when the goodness and loving kindness of God our Savior appeared, he saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit, whom he poured out on us richly through Jesus Christ our Savior, so that being justified by his grace we might become heirs according to the hope of eternal life.” Here the Father, Son, and Spirit all work for our salvation. It is entirely mercy; it is new birth; it makes us heirs.

Paul concludes: insist on these things, so that believers will devote themselves to good works. Avoid foolish controversies. Warn a divisive person once, then twice, and then have nothing to do with him. The letter ends with practical greetings and the blessing, “Grace be with you all.”

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 2:8-10 also joins salvation by grace with good works. Romans 6:1-4 answers whether grace excuses sin. John 3:3-8 and 1 Peter 1:3 speak of new birth. Romans 5:1-2 and 8:17 speak of justification and heirs. Deuteronomy 7:6 and 1 Peter 2:9 speak of a people for God’s own possession. 2 Peter 1:1 and John 20:28 also call Christ God. Matthew 28:19 names Father, Son, and Spirit. Romans 13:1-7 speaks of rulers. James 2:14-26 joins faith and works. Matthew 5:16 speaks of good works glorifying the Father.

STEP 6

Application

Read 2:11-14 slowly. Underline each work of grace: it appears, saves, trains, redeems, purifies.

Pick one “good work” you can do for someone this week as a fruit of grace, and do it.

Remember the person you were before Christ (3:3) the next time you are tempted to be harsh with someone.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for redeeming you and purifying a people for himself.
- Ask him to make you zealous for good works.
- Ask him to keep you from foolish arguments.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 117

“All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work.”

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17

DAY 817 · WEEK 117

Philemon 1:1-25

Onesimus, grace transforms every relationship

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 25 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Philemon, a one-chapter letter. It is Paul's most personal letter, a short appeal on behalf of a runaway slave named Onesimus. Read it slowly, imagining Philemon opening it before the whole church that meets in his house.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Philemon was a wealthy Christian in Colossae, with a church in his house. His slave Onesimus ran away, perhaps after stealing, and somehow met Paul in prison, where he became a Christian. Paul is sending Onesimus back, with this letter, asking Philemon to receive him not as a slave but as a beloved brother. It was sent with the Colossian letter, carried by Tychicus and Onesimus (Colossians 4:7-9).

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I thank my God always when I remember you in my prayers, because I hear of your love and of the faith that you have toward the Lord Jesus and for all the saints" (vv. 4-5).
2. "For this reason, though I am bold enough in Christ to command you to do what is required, yet for love's sake I prefer to appeal to you" (vv. 8-9).
3. "I appeal to you for my child, Onesimus, whom I have begotten in my imprisonment" (v. 10).
4. "Formerly he was useless to you, but now he is indeed useful to you and to me" (v. 11).
5. "No longer as a bondservant but more than a bondservant, as a beloved brother" (v. 16).
6. "So if you consider me your partner, receive him as you would receive me" (v. 17).
7. "If he has wronged you at all, or owes you anything, charge that to my account" (v. 18).

8 “Confident of your obedience, I write to you, knowing that you will do even more than I say” (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul writes as a prisoner of Christ Jesus, with Timothy, to Philemon, Apphia, Archippus, and the church in the house. He begins with thanks for Philemon’s love and faith, and prays that the sharing of his faith may become effective for the full knowledge of every good thing in Christ. Paul has “derived much joy and comfort from your love, because the hearts of the saints have been refreshed through you, my brother.” This builds up goodwill before the request.

Then the appeal. Paul could command, but “for love’s sake I prefer to appeal to you.” The appeal is for Onesimus, whose name means “useful.” Paul puns on it: “Formerly he was useless to you, but now he is indeed useful to you and to me.” Paul calls Onesimus his child and says, “I am sending him back to you, sending my very heart.” He would have liked to keep him, but would do nothing without Philemon’s consent, “in order that your goodness might not be by compulsion but of your own accord.”

Paul offers a perspective on the situation: “For this perhaps is why he was parted from you for a while, that you might have him back forever, no longer as a bondservant but more than a bondservant, as a beloved brother.” Providence may have been at work. Onesimus is a brother both in the flesh and in the Lord. Then Paul puts himself in the middle: “So if you consider me your partner, receive him as you would receive me. If he has wronged you at all, or owes you anything, charge that to my account. I, Paul, write this with my own hand: I will repay it.” He adds, gently, that Philemon owes Paul his very self.

This is a picture of the gospel. Onesimus, the guilty one, owes a debt. Paul, the innocent, steps in and says, charge it to me. Receive him as you would receive me. This is imputation: the debt of the guilty is put on the account of another, and the standing of the innocent is given to the guilty. Christ does this for us before the Father. We are welcomed because we come in his name.

The letter does not directly attack slavery as an institution, though it undermines its foundations by declaring a slave a brother and by asking that he be received as Paul himself. Elsewhere Paul lists slave traders among the lawless (1 Timothy 1:10), and the principle that in Christ there is neither slave nor free (Galatians 3:28) worked itself out over time. Paul closes by expressing confidence that Philemon will do even more than he asks, and asks for a guest room, hoping to be released. He sends greetings from Epaphras, Mark, Aristarchus, Demas, and Luke.

STEP 5

Connection

Colossians 4:7-9 mentions Onesimus. Galatians 3:28 and Colossians 3:11 declare that in Christ there is neither slave nor free. 1 Corinthians 7:21-24 speaks to slaves. Ephesians 6:5-9 gives instruction to slaves and masters. 1 Timothy 6:1-2 mentions believing masters. Isaiah 53:4-6 and 2 Corinthians 5:21 speak of Christ taking our debt. Romans 8:1 assures there is no condemnation. Matthew 18:21-35 teaches forgiveness. Luke 15:20-24 pictures the welcome of the returning son.

STEP 6

Application

Is there someone you need to forgive or receive back? Take a step this week, in the spirit of Paul's appeal.

Read the letter again, putting yourself in Onesimus's place, and thank Christ for standing in for you.

Think about whom you may stand beside in an appeal for mercy or justice.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for taking your debt on himself.
- Ask him to show you a relationship that needs the grace you have received.
- Ask him to help you receive others as brothers and sisters.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 117

"All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work."

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17

DAY 818 · WEEK 117

Review and Reflection

Unit 22 review, In Christ, Prison & Pastoral Epistles

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation. For by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth."
>
> COLOSSIANS 1:15-16

REST

Meditation

Paul lifts our eyes to Christ. He is "the image of the invisible God." No one has seen God, but we see him in Jesus. He is "the firstborn of all creation," which means he has the rank and inheritance of the firstborn, not that he was created. "For by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities." The powers that the Colossians feared are creatures, made by him and for him.

This verse is the foundation of the whole Prison and Pastoral section. If Christ is this great, we are secure in him, the church is his body, our work is for him, and our hope is his appearing. Say it slowly. Each phrase is a reason to worship.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

This unit took us through the Prison and Pastoral Epistles. Ephesians showed us God's plan from eternity: chosen in Christ, saved by grace through faith, made one new people, and equipped to walk in love, light, and the whole armor of God. Psalms 68 and 110 celebrated the ascended Christ as priest-king. Philippians showed joy in chains, the humility and exaltation of Christ in the great hymn, and the surpassing worth of knowing him. Colossians declared the supremacy of Christ over all things and taught us to live in him, setting our minds on things above and doing everything in the name of the Lord Jesus. We paused to consider election, the church, the person of Christ as fully God and fully man, and ordinary work as a calling. In 1 and 2 Thessalonians, we learned to wait for the Lord's return with hope and with work, and to stand firm in persecution. Psalms 27, 138, and 139 taught us to

seek the LORD's face, give thanks with the whole heart, and be searched and led by the one who made us. In 1 Timothy we learned how the household of God should live, with sound doctrine, prayer, and godly leaders. In 2 Timothy we heard Paul's last words: guard the gospel, rightly handle the word, and trust that all Scripture is breathed out by God. Titus showed how grace trains us for good works, and Philemon showed the gospel at work in one friendship, with Paul standing in for the guilty.

REFLECT

Review Questions

Ephesians 2:8-10 and Titus 3:4-7 both say we are saved by grace, not works, and yet for good works. How do these fit together?

Write in your own words how salvation by grace leads to a life of good works, and give an example from your own life.

Philippians 2:5-11 and Colossians 1:15-20 both describe Christ. What do they teach about who he is and what he has done?

List three truths about Christ from these passages and say how each strengthens your trust or worship.

Paul writes many of these letters from prison. What do Philippians and 2 Timothy show about how a believer can face hardship?

Choose a hardship you or someone you know is facing and apply one truth from these letters.

2 Timothy 3:16-17 says all Scripture is breathed out by God. What difference does this make to how you read the Bible?

Describe one change you will make to your reading habits, based on what Scripture is and what it does.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the letters of Paul and what they have taught you.

Thank him for Christ in whom all things hold together.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

DAY 819 · WEEK 117

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Timothy 3:16-17 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work."

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17

REST

Meditation

This is the Bible's own testimony about itself. "All Scripture" means every part, not just our favorite passages. "Breathed out by God" means it comes from him, carrying his authority and truthfulness. It is not merely helpful human wisdom.

Then the four purposes: teaching (what to believe), reproof (where we are wrong), correction (how to get back on the path), and training in righteousness (how to grow). Notice that Scripture does not only inform us; it forms us. It confronts and repairs us.

The goal is "that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work." This verse applies to every believer, not only to pastors. God's word is enough to equip us for what he calls us to do. The next time you open the Bible, pray this verse first, and ask the Spirit to do each of the four things.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the Pastoral Epistles. First Timothy 4 to 6 taught that everything God created is good, that godliness is of value in every way, and that the love of money is a root of all kinds of evils. Second Timothy 1 and 2 gave Paul's farewell charge: a spirit of power, love, and self-control; guard the deposit; entrust the gospel to faithful people; and rightly handle the word of truth. Second Timothy 3 and 4 gave the great statement of Scripture's inspiration and Paul's last testimony: I have fought the good fight, finished the race, kept the faith. Titus joined sound doctrine with good works and gave two summaries of the gospel. Philemon pictured the gospel in a personal appeal, with Paul saying, charge it to my account. On Day 818 we reviewed the whole Prison and Pastoral unit.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, reproof, correction, and training in righteousness. Which of these four do you most need from the Bible right now, and what passage might you read for it?

In Philemon, Paul offers to take on Onesimus's debt. How does this help you understand what Christ has done for you, and how might it shape your relationship with someone who has wronged you?

Paul ends his life saying, "I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith." What would you want to be able to say at the end of your life? What is one step toward it this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his breathed-out word, able to make you wise for salvation.

Ask him to equip you for every good work.

Rest in him.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 23 · DAYS 820-836

The Better Covenant: Hebrews

Hebrews 1-13

Jesus is the fulfillment of every type, shadow, and promise in the Old Testament.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses... Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace."

HEBREWS 4:15-16

Psalms 95, 40, 110, and 22, which Hebrews quotes.

UNIT 23

In this unit

WEEK 118

820	Hebrews 1:1-2:18	*Reading*
821	Hebrews 3:1-4:13	*Reading*
822	Hebrews 4:14-6:20	*Reading*
823	Psalm 95	*Psalm*
824	Psalm 40:1-10	*Psalm*
825	Psalm 110	*Psalm*
826	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 119

827	Hebrews 7:1-28	*Reading*
828	Hebrews 8:1-9:28	*Reading*
829	Hebrews 10:1-39	*Reading*
830	Acts 2:42-47; Hebrews 10:24-25	*Doctrine*
831	Hebrews 11:1-40	*Reading*
832	Hebrews 12:1-29	*Reading*
833	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 120

834	Hebrews 13:1-25	*Reading*
835	Psalm 22	*Psalm*
836	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 820 · WEEK 118

Hebrews 1:1-2:18

The Son above angels; the founder of salvation

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 1:1-2:18 in one sitting if you can. Hebrews does not begin like a letter. It begins like a sermon, and it starts by announcing who Jesus is. As you read, count the ways the author describes the Son and notice how often he quotes the Old Testament to prove it. Don't worry about catching every reference. Let the weight of the opening sentence settle on you.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

We are about to begin a book unlike any other in the New Testament. Hebrews has no greeting, no named author, and no named recipients. It opens with a single, majestic sentence in Greek and moves quickly into a sustained argument. The original readers were Jewish Christians who were under pressure. They were tempted to retreat from Christ and return to the safer, more familiar patterns of Moses and the temple. The author's response is not to scold them first but to show them Jesus. Everything depends on seeing that the Son is better than anything they might be tempted to go back to. For us, the book is a gift because it explains, from the inside, how the entire Old Testament points to Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God spoke "long ago" by the prophets in many portions and ways, but "in these last days" by his Son (1:1-2).
2. The Son is heir of all things and the agent through whom the world was made (1:2).
3. He is "the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature," and he upholds the universe by his word (1:3).

4. After making purification for sins, he “sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high” (1:3).
5. Hebrews 1:5-13 strings together seven Old Testament quotations to show that the Son is superior to angels.
6. Hebrews 1:8 applies the word “God” to the Son: “Your throne, O God, is forever and ever.”
7. Hebrews 2:1-4 is the first of several warnings: “we must pay much closer attention to what we have heard.”
8. Hebrews 2:14-18 explains that the Son shared in flesh and blood so that through death he might destroy the devil and free those who feared death.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first four verses of Hebrews are one of the most compressed statements of Christology in the Bible. The author begins with a contrast that organizes the whole book: God spoke before, and God has now spoken in a final way. The prophets were real messengers with real messages, delivered in pieces and fragments. But the Son is not another fragment. He is the full and final word. Everything the prophets pointed toward has now arrived in a person.

Then come the seven descriptions of the Son. He is heir, which means everything belongs to him. He is the agent of creation, which echoes John 1 and Colossians 1. He is the radiance of God’s glory, like light that streams from the sun and shares its nature. He is the exact imprint of God’s being, like the impression stamped by a seal. He sustains all things by his powerful word. He made purification for sins. And he sat down. That last detail matters: a priest in the old covenant never sat, because the work was never finished. Christ sat because his work was done.

Having established who the Son is, the author turns to prove it from Scripture, and he starts with angels. This may seem odd to us, but in Jewish thought angels were awesome mediators of God’s law (see Acts 7:53 and Galatians 3:19). To say the Son is greater than angels is to say he is greater than the mediation that came through them. The seven quotations in chapter 1 are drawn from the Psalms and the prophets, and they are all applied to Jesus. The most striking is verse 8, where the Father himself says to the Son, “Your throne, O God, is forever and ever.” The Father addresses the Son as God.

Chapter 2 opens with a warning that the author will repeat in different forms. If the message delivered through angels was binding and every transgression received a just penalty, how can we escape if we neglect so great a salvation? Notice the verb. The danger is not primarily active rebellion but drifting. The slow, quiet neglect of Christ is how many people leave him.

The rest of chapter 2 turns from the Son's glory to his humiliation, and it is a beautiful turn. How can the one who is greater than angels be made "for a little while lower than the angels"? Because he came to taste death for everyone. The one who made the world entered it, took on flesh and blood, and died. Verses 14-15 tell us why: to destroy the one who has the power of death, the devil, and to deliver those who all their lives were enslaved by fear. Fear of death is a master, and Christ has broken its power.

Verse 17 introduces a theme that will dominate the book: he had to be made like his brothers in every respect, so that he might become a merciful and faithful high priest. The Son who is God became truly human so he could represent us before God. He is not simply above us. He is with us, and he is for us.

STEP 5

Connection

The seven descriptions in 1:1-4 echo Proverbs 8 and Wisdom language, Genesis 1 (creation by word), and Psalm 110:1 (the session at God's right hand). The quotations in chapter 1 draw from Psalm 2, 2 Samuel 7, Deuteronomy 32, Psalm 45, Psalm 102, and Psalm 110, which is a sweep of the Old Testament's royal and creation theology. Chapter 2 draws on Psalm 8, where humanity is crowned with glory and honor, and Hebrews shows that Jesus is the true Man who fulfills that calling. Later in the book, 2:17 prepares us for Hebrews 4:14-5:10 and 7:1-28.

STEP 6

Application

First, take the opening verse as a personal challenge: God has spoken. Do you treat his word as final? Resolve to read Scripture this week as the voice of the Son, not as a collection of tips.

Second, notice the warning about drifting. Few believers wake up one day and decide to abandon Christ. They stop praying, then stop reading, then stop gathering. Ask yourself which small habits are keeping you attentive to him, and which neglected habits are pulling you off course.

Third, if you fear death, in any of its forms, remember what verse 15 says. Christ has freed those who were enslaved. You can begin to say honestly that you are afraid and ask him to deal with it. He understands, and he has already won.

Fourth, take comfort that the Son is not embarrassed by you. Hebrews 2:11 says he is not ashamed to call you brother.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for speaking to you by his Son.

Ask him to keep you from drifting.

Ask him to open your ears to hear him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 118

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."

HEBREWS 1:3

DAY 821 · WEEK 118

Hebrews 3:1-4:13

Greater than Moses; the Sabbath rest remains

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 3:1-4:13. This is a long reading with a single theme: the danger of an unbelieving heart and the promise of God's rest. Keep your finger on the repeated phrase from Psalm 95, "Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts." It appears three times, and each time it presses on the reader.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Having shown that the Son is greater than angels, the author now compares him with Moses. For a Jewish audience, this was the more sensitive comparison. Moses was the lawgiver, the faithful servant, the man who spoke with God face to face. To suggest anyone is greater than Moses was bold. But the point is not to diminish Moses. It is to show that Moses himself pointed forward. Then the author turns to the wilderness generation, those who were delivered from Egypt but failed to enter the promised land because of unbelief. The warning is plain: do not follow their example. The promise of rest is still open.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Jesus is called the "apostle and high priest of our confession" (3:1). He is both sent from God and sent to God on our behalf.
2. Moses was faithful "as a servant in all God's house," but Christ is faithful "as a son over God's house" (3:5-6).
3. The house is built by God, and "we are his house if indeed we hold fast our confidence" (3:6).
4. Psalm 95:7-11 is quoted at length and applied to the readers: "Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts" (3:7-8).

5. The wilderness generation died because of unbelief and disobedience (3:16-19).
6. "A promise remains" of entering God's rest (4:1), and the readers are told to strive to enter it (4:11).
7. The gospel was preached to the wilderness generation, but it did not benefit them because they were not united by faith with those who listened (4:2).
8. The word of God is described as living, active, and sharper than a two-edged sword, discerning the thoughts and intentions of the heart (4:12-13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The comparison with Moses is one of respect and fulfillment. Both Moses and Jesus were faithful to God's house, but they hold different positions. Moses was a servant in the house, and he served well. Jesus is the Son over the house, and in fact the builder of it. A house is always inferior to its builder, and a servant is always inferior to the son. This is not a criticism of Moses but a recognition that Moses' faithful service was itself a testimony pointing forward to someone greater. Numbers 12:7 calls Moses faithful in all God's house. Hebrews says: yes, and now the Son has come.

The conditional phrase in 3:6 deserves attention: "we are his house if indeed we hold fast our confidence." This is the first appearance of a theme that runs through Hebrews. The author is not suggesting that believers earn their place in God's house by perseverance. Rather, perseverance is how true faith shows itself. Those who belong to Christ will hold fast to him, and the warnings are God's means of keeping them holding on.

Next the author reaches into Psalm 95 and applies it to his readers. The wilderness generation saw God's mighty works. They were rescued from Egypt, fed with manna, and guided by the cloud. And yet they rebelled and tested God. The author's diagnosis is clear: "an evil, unbelieving heart" that leads to falling away from the living God. The remedy is just as clear: exhort one another every day, as long as it is called "today," so that none of you may be hardened by the deceitfulness of sin. Notice that the remedy is communal. Faith is not a private possession but something we guard together.

Chapter 4 develops the idea of rest. In Genesis 2, God rested on the seventh day. In Joshua, Israel entered the land. But Psalm 95, written centuries after Joshua, still speaks of a rest to enter "today." The author's reasoning is that if Joshua had given them the final rest, David would not have spoken of another day. Therefore "there remains a Sabbath rest for the people of God." The rest is the fullness of salvation, communion with God, and relief from

striving to earn his favor. It is entered by faith, and it is fully enjoyed when Christ returns. We enter it now in part by trusting his finished work, and we will enter it fully in the new creation.

The urgency of verse 11, "Let us strive to enter that rest," sounds paradoxical. How do you strive to rest? The answer is that you strive against unbelief. The effort is to keep trusting, to keep coming back to Christ, and to refuse to harden your heart.

The section ends with a vivid picture of the word of God. It is living, active, and piercing. It exposes our hearts. Nothing is hidden from the one with whom we have to do. This is frightening if we are hiding, but it is also the basis for confidence, because the God who sees everything is the one who has provided a high priest.

STEP 5

Connection

The Moses comparison draws on Numbers 12 and Exodus 33:11, where Moses speaks with God face to face. The warning from Psalm 95 looks back to the rebellions at Massah and Meribah (Exodus 17, Numbers 14), which you read earlier in this plan. The theme of rest links Genesis 2:2, Exodus 20:8-11, Deuteronomy 12:9-10, and Joshua 21:44. Jesus himself offers this rest in Matthew 11:28-30. The living word of 4:12 echoes Isaiah 55:10-11 and prepares for the high priest passage that immediately follows.

STEP 6

Application

First, take the word "today" seriously. If you have been delaying obedience or repentance, today is the day to hear his voice. Choose one thing you know the Lord is asking of you, and do it.

Second, ask whether you are keeping up the daily exhortation Hebrews commands. Who is encouraging you in the faith? Who are you encouraging? If no one, take a first step this week toward someone in your church.

Third, think about rest. Many believers live as if salvation depends on constant effort. The Sabbath rest that remains is in part the rest of knowing that Christ has finished the work. Let your weekly rest day be a regular practice of trusting that.

Fourth, let Hebrews 4:12 shape how you read Scripture. Bring your heart to the word, expecting it to read you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God that today you hear his voice, and ask him to soften your heart.

Confess where you have hardened your heart.

Thank him for the rest that remains.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 118

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."

HEBREWS 1:3

DAY 822 · WEEK 118

Hebrews 4:14-6:20

The great high priest; warning and assurance

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 38 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 4:14-6:20. The reading has three movements: the invitation to draw near to a sympathetic high priest, the qualifications of a priest, and a sober warning followed by a promise. Slow down at 6:4-8 and 6:9-12. The warning is real, and so is the author's confidence that his readers will persevere.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The author has spoken of Jesus as a great high priest. Now he stops to explain what that means. A priest stands between God and humanity, offering gifts and sacrifices on behalf of the people. In Israel the priests came from the tribe of Levi and the high priest from the line of Aaron. How could Jesus be a priest when he came from Judah? The author's answer introduces a mysterious figure from Genesis 14 and Psalm 110: Melchizedek. But before he can fully explain, he pauses to rebuke his readers for being slow to understand and to warn them against falling away. Then he ends the chapter with one of the most encouraging passages in the New Testament, on the certainty of God's promise.

STEP 3

Observation

1. 4:14-16 repeats the call to hold fast and gives the invitation to draw near to the throne of grace.
2. A high priest is chosen from among men to act on their behalf, and he can deal gently with the ignorant because he is beset by weakness himself (5:1-3).
3. Christ did not exalt himself to be a high priest. The Father called him with the words of Psalm 2 and Psalm 110 (5:5-6).

4. “In the days of his flesh,” Jesus offered up prayers with loud cries and tears, and “he learned obedience through what he suffered” (5:7-8).
5. The readers are called “dull of hearing” and still needing milk when they should be teachers (5:11-14).
6. 6:1-2 lists elementary teachings: repentance, faith, baptisms, laying on of hands, resurrection, and judgment.
7. 6:4-6 describes those who have been enlightened and tasted the heavenly gift, and then fallen away.
8. God swore by himself so that by two unchangeable things we might have strong encouragement, an anchor of the soul (6:13-20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The passage opens by repeating the invitation. The repetition is deliberate. Having just warned his readers, the author immediately offers hope. We have a high priest. Come to the throne of grace. Between the warning and the hope, he wants them to see that the answer to weakness is not retreat but nearness.

Chapter 5 sets out what a priest is and shows that Jesus qualifies. The two qualifications are sympathy and appointment. A high priest must be able to deal gently with those who stray because he knows his own weakness. Jesus meets this qualification not through sin but through suffering. “In the days of his flesh” refers to his earthly life, and verse 7 almost certainly points to Gethsemane. The Son offered prayers with loud cries and tears. This is the picture of a Savior who knows what it is to pray in agony. He “learned obedience through what he suffered.” This does not mean he was ever disobedient, but that he experienced obedience at its hardest cost. Having been “made perfect,” he became the source of eternal salvation to all who obey him. The second qualification is appointment: Jesus did not claim the office for himself. The Father called him, and Psalm 110:4 identifies his priesthood as “after the order of Melchizedek.”

At this point, the author’s thought stalls. He has much to say about Melchizedek, but his readers are sluggish. They should be teachers, yet they need to be taught the basics again. The rebuke is pastoral rather than cruel, and it is a challenge to every Christian: are you growing? Solid food belongs to the mature, those who have trained themselves by practice to distinguish good from evil.

Then comes the warning in 6:4-8. It is one of the most debated passages in the Bible, and honest interpreters disagree. The best reading, in line with the whole letter, is that the author describes those who have shared in the visible blessings of the church community,

heard the word, and tasted its power, but who then deliberately and finally reject Christ. For such a person, there is no second sacrifice. If Christ's sacrifice is rejected, nothing else remains. The author illustrates with farmland: the same rain falls on the field that bears fruit and the field that bears thorns. The question is what the field produces.

But the author does not leave his readers terrified. "Though we speak in this way, yet in your case, beloved, we feel sure of better things." The evidence of genuine faith is love shown through service to the saints, and the author wants them to keep it up to the end. Warnings and assurance are not enemies. The warnings are the means God uses to keep his people.

The chapter ends with a stunning image. God made a promise to Abraham and, because he had no one greater to swear by, swore by himself. A promise and an oath are two unchangeable things in which it is impossible for God to lie. This is the foundation of our confidence. Our hope is an anchor for the soul, firm and secure, and it enters "into the inner place behind the curtain" where Jesus has gone as a forerunner on our behalf. The anchor does not hold from the ship's side but from the harbor. Our hope is anchored in heaven, in the person of Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

The call of Jesus as priest from Psalm 110:4 links to your reading of Psalm 110 in this unit and to Genesis 14, where Abram met Melchizedek. The oath to Abraham comes from Genesis 22:16-17 and ties to the Abrahamic covenant you read in Unit 3. The picture of the field with thorns recalls Genesis 3:17-18 and Isaiah 5. Gethsemane in 5:7 anticipates Matthew 26, Mark 14, and Luke 22. The inner place behind the curtain points forward to the temple imagery of Hebrews 9-10.

STEP 6

Application

First, check your growth. Hebrews calls the readers to move beyond milk. What is one area of your faith, such as prayer, Scripture, or serving, in which you have stayed at the beginner level? Choose one concrete step to deepen it.

Second, treat the warning as a gift. If you feel a pull to drift or give up, do not hide it. Bring it to the Lord and to a trusted believer. The warnings exist to keep you close.

Third, rest in the oath of God. When you feel that your hold on God is slipping, remember that your hope does not rest in your grip but in his promise. The anchor holds you.

Fourth, draw near this week. Pray as someone who knows that Jesus has been where you are.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that he is a high priest who knows what it is to weep and pray.

Ask him to keep you from sluggishness and give you hope as an anchor.

Draw near to his throne of grace and tell him what you need.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 118

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."

HEBREWS 1:3

DAY 823 · WEEK 118

Psalm 95

Today, if you hear his voice, Hebrews' warning psalm

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 95 aloud, slowly. Notice that it has two halves with very different moods. The first calls us to joyful worship, and the second turns suddenly to warning. Hebrews quoted the second half in the last two days of readings. Today you read the whole psalm in its original setting.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 95 was likely sung as a call to worship as pilgrims approached the temple. It begins with exuberant singing and ends with an alarm. The author of Hebrews took the final verses and made them the center of his warning in chapters 3 and 4. Reading the whole psalm helps us hear what he heard: worship and obedience are inseparable. To sing to the LORD with joy and then to harden your heart against his voice is a contradiction. The psalm asks us to come in, bow down, and listen.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with a call to sing and shout joyfully to "the rock of our salvation" (v. 1).
2. The LORD is called a great God and a great King above all gods (v. 3).
3. His is the depths of the earth, the heights of the mountains, the sea, and the dry land (vv. 4-5).
4. The invitation changes from singing to kneeling: "let us worship and bow down" (v. 6).
5. "He is our God, and we are the people of his pasture, and the sheep of his hand" (v. 7).
6. Verse 7 pivots mid-sentence: "Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts."

7. The warning cites Meribah and Massah, where Israel tested God in the wilderness (vv. 8-9).

8. The psalm ends with God's oath that the rebellious generation "shall not enter my rest" (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The structure of Psalm 95 is a lesson in itself. It moves from praising God as Creator (vv. 1-5) to worshiping him as Shepherd (vv. 6-7a) to hearing him as Judge (vv. 7b-11). Each stage deepens the relationship. The God who made everything is also the God who made us his flock, and the God who speaks to us. Genuine worship always includes listening.

The first section calls for noise. Come into his presence with thanksgiving, make a joyful noise with songs of praise. The reason is given immediately: he is a great God, and the whole created order is in his hands. The depths of the earth and the peaks of the mountains both belong to him. The sea is his because he made it. Nothing is outside his reach.

Then the psalm calls for a different posture. The singing gives way to bowing. "Come, let us worship and bow down; let us kneel before the LORD, our Maker." The Creator is also our Maker, which means he has authority over us and care for us. Verse 7 puts it tenderly: "we are the people of his pasture, and the sheep of his hand." A good shepherd leads, and sheep follow. The psalmist is about to say what following requires.

The turn comes in the middle of verse 7: "Today, if you hear his voice." The relationship is not one of passive admiration. God speaks. The test of worship is the response to what he says. The warning that follows reaches back to the wilderness. At Meribah and Massah, the people grumbled for water even though they had seen the plagues and the sea divided. They tested God, demanding he prove himself again. For forty years God was grieved with that generation. The result was that they did not enter the rest he had promised.

The author of Hebrews uses this as a sober example for the church. Those who are the sheep of God's hand must listen to the shepherd. The call to today means that obedience cannot wait. Whenever the word of God comes, that is the day to respond.

Read as a whole, the psalm is not a contradiction between joy and fear. It shows that the deepest joy is found in submission to a God who is both great and good. The people who sing the loudest are the ones who also listen.

STEP 5

Connection

This psalm is quoted in Hebrews 3:7-11, 3:15, and 4:3-7. Its background is Exodus 17:1-7 and Numbers 20:1-13, where the people quarreled at Meribah and Massah. The shepherd imagery connects to Psalm 23 and Ezekiel 34, and finds its fulfillment in Jesus' words in John 10: "I am the good shepherd." The "rest" that Israel failed to enter looks back to Deuteronomy 12:9 and forward to the Sabbath rest of Hebrews 4.

STEP 6

Application

Use Psalm 95 as a Sunday morning pattern. Sing, kneel, and listen. If you are tempted to treat worship as entertainment, notice that the psalm calls for attention to God's voice. Before your next church service, ask the Lord to speak to you through the sermon, and be ready to obey.

Think about Meribah. Where are you demanding that God prove himself again? Are there areas where you have seen him provide and still grumble? Name one, and thank him instead.

Finally, remember that your shepherd has a name. The Lord who calls you his sheep is Jesus, who laid down his life for you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship God as rock of your salvation and shepherd of your soul.
- Tell him you want to hear his voice and not harden your heart.
- Thank him that he is your Maker.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 118

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."

HEBREWS 1:3

DAY 824 · WEEK 118

Psalm 40:1-10

I delight to do your will, the Son's voice

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 40:1-10 and then glance at Hebrews 10:5-10 where this psalm is quoted. The psalm is David's, but Hebrews hears it as the voice of the Son speaking to the Father. Read it twice, once as David's testimony and once as Christ's.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In Hebrews 2 and 10, the author puts Old Testament psalms into the mouth of Jesus, treating them as the speech of the Son to the Father. Psalm 40 is one of these. In its original setting, David gives thanks for rescue from a pit and declares his joy in doing the will of God rather than offering mere sacrifices. Hebrews will take verses 6-8 and show that they find their fullest meaning in Christ, who came into the world to do the Father's will by offering his own body. Today we read the psalm ahead of that application, so we are ready to hear it when we get there.

STEP 3

Observation

1. David waited patiently for the LORD, and the LORD "inclined to me and heard my cry" (v. 1).
2. God lifted him from a "pit of destruction" and "the miry bog" and set his feet on a rock (v. 2).
3. God put "a new song in my mouth, a song of praise to our God" (v. 3).
4. Many will see and fear and put their trust in the LORD (v. 3).
5. "Sacrifice and offering you have not desired, but you have given me an open ear" (v. 6).
6. "Then I said, 'Behold, I have come; in the scroll of the book it is written of me'" (v. 7).

7. “I delight to do your will, O my God; your law is within my heart” (v. 8).
8. David has told the glad news of deliverance “in the great congregation” and has not restrained his lips (vv. 9-10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a testimony. David was in a pit, a place of helplessness, and he waited. The word suggests a long wait, and he does not complain but credits the LORD for hearing. The rescue is complete: the pit is replaced with a rock, and the mud with firm ground. And a new song fills his mouth. Rescue always produces praise.

Notice what happens next. David does not pretend that he can repay God. In verse 6, he says something surprising: “Sacrifice and offering you have not desired.” This was not a rejection of the sacrificial system, which God himself instituted, but a reminder that the sacrifices were never the point. What God wanted was an obedient heart. “You have given me an open ear.” The phrase may refer to a servant who willingly listens to his master. God wants those who hear him and respond.

Then David says, “Behold, I have come; in the scroll of the book it is written of me.” In David’s setting, this likely refers to the king’s duty described in the law (Deuteronomy 17:18-20). But Hebrews 10 reads it as the voice of Christ. When the Son came into the world, he said, “a body have you prepared for me” (the Greek translation of verse 6 that Hebrews quotes). The animal sacrifices could not take away sins. So Christ came, and he said: “I have come to do your will, O God.” By that will, we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all.

This is how the New Testament reads the Old. David’s experience is real, but it is also a shadow. His delight in doing God’s will is a faint picture of the perfect delight of the Son. His rescue from the pit is a hint of the great rescue from the grave. His proclamation in the great congregation looks ahead to the gospel going to the nations.

The last verses make an important point about testimony. David does not hide his deliverance. He proclaims God’s faithfulness and salvation and does not conceal his steadfast love. We are rescued so that others will see and trust.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 40:6-8 is quoted in Hebrews 10:5-7 and is the voice of Christ as he comes into the world. The “open ear” recalls Isaiah 50:4-5, the Servant who listens and does not turn back. The rescue from the pit resonates with Joseph in Genesis 37, Jonah 2, and Psalm 30. The

priority of obedience over sacrifice appears in 1 Samuel 15:22, Psalm 51:16-17, and Micah 6:6-8. “I delight to do your will” is the heart of Jesus’ own words in John 4:34 and Matthew 26:39.

STEP 6

Application

Think about the pit you have been rescued from. It may be sin, shame, fear, or something else. Write a short testimony of what God did, even just a few sentences. David did not hide his story, and your story may be what someone else needs to hear.

Examine your sense of delight. Do you obey God out of duty only, or is there any joy in it? Ask the Lord for the heart of the psalm: “your law is within my heart.” It is a gift, and Christ has given you his Spirit to produce it.

Finally, thank Jesus for saying what you could not say. He came to do the Father’s will. Because he did, you are free to approach.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for drawing you out of the pit and putting a new song in your mouth.

Thank him for the Son who came to do his will.

Ask him to give you delight in doing it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 118

“He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high.”

HEBREWS 1:3

DAY 825 · WEEK 118

Psalm 110

Priest forever after the order of Melchizedek

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 110. It is only seven verses long, but it is the most quoted psalm in the New Testament. Read it slowly and mark the two oaths: God's promise to make the king sit at his right hand, and his oath that the king is also a priest forever. Note how the Lord speaks to "my Lord."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

David wrote this psalm, and Jesus himself used it to stump the religious leaders. In Mark 12:35-37, Jesus asked how David could call the Messiah "my Lord" if the Messiah was merely David's son. The psalm contains a puzzle that is solved only in the person of Jesus. It pictures a king who is also a priest, which was forbidden in Israel, and who reigns at God's right hand over his enemies. Hebrews returns to this psalm repeatedly. In the unit you are reading now, Psalm 110 is the foundation of the argument that Christ is a high priest after the order of Melchizedek.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD says to my Lord" (v. 1). David, the king, speaks of another who is his Lord.
2. The Lord is told to sit at the right hand of God until his enemies are made his footstool (v. 1).
3. The scepter of the king will extend from Zion, and he will rule in the midst of his enemies (v. 2).
4. His people offer themselves freely on the day of his power, "in holy garments" (v. 3).
5. "The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind: You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek" (v. 4).

6. The Lord at God's right hand will shatter kings on the day of his wrath and execute judgment among the nations (vv. 5-6).
7. The last verse is surprising: "He will drink from the brook by the way; therefore he will lift up his head" (v. 7).
8. The psalm combines two offices that never met in Israel, king and priest.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 110 is a royal psalm with an astonishing claim. The first verse is a conversation within God. "The LORD" (Yahweh) speaks to "my Lord" (Adonai), and invites him to sit at his right hand. David was the king of Israel, and no one was above him except God. So who is this Lord whom David calls his own? Jesus raised exactly this question, and the New Testament gives the answer: the Messiah is David's son and David's Lord. He is the descendant who is also the divine Son.

Verses 1-3 describe his reign. He sits at God's right hand, the place of authority, until his enemies are subdued. The conquest does not depend on his strength alone, because the LORD himself puts the enemies under his feet. Yet verse 2 adds that he rules from Zion in the midst of his enemies. He is already reigning, even though his enemies are not yet fully defeated. This is the "already and not yet" of the kingdom. And verse 3 says his people will volunteer on the day of his power. They are not conscripted but willing, clothed in holiness.

Verse 4 is the center of the psalm. "The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind: You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek." Two things stand out. First, God takes an oath. The Levitical priests were not appointed with an oath, but this priest is. Second, he is a priest forever, which means his priesthood has no end. The order of Melchizedek is not the Levitical order. It is the order of the priest-king who met Abraham in Genesis 14 and blessed him. This verse is the hinge of Hebrews 5-7. Hebrews argues that if there is a new priest of a different order, then the Levitical priesthood was never intended to be final.

The rest of the psalm describes judgment. The Lord at God's right hand will shatter kings and fill the places with corpses. This language is graphic, and it is meant to be. The reign of Christ includes the defeat of every evil power. Yet the final image is not one of bloodshed but of weariness: he drinks from a brook along the way and lifts up his head. The conquering king pauses to drink. He is human, and his victory is won in a body that gets thirsty.

The psalm gathers the two great themes of the book of Hebrews: Christ is a king who reigns, and a priest who intercedes. He sits because his work is finished, and he reigns because his enemies will be subdued.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 110:1 is quoted in Matthew 22:44, Acts 2:34-35, and Hebrews 1:13. Verse 4 is quoted in Hebrews 5:6, 7:17, and 7:21. The priest-king Melchizedek appears in Genesis 14:18-20, which you read in Unit 3. The Davidic promise of 2 Samuel 7 supports the royal side, and Zechariah 6:12-13 anticipates a priest who will sit and rule on his throne. The footstool imagery recalls Joshua 10:24 and 1 Corinthians 15:25.

STEP 6

Application

Pause to consider that the one who sits at God's right hand is also the one who prays for you. The reigning king and the sympathetic priest are the same person. Whatever you are afraid of, he rules over it, and whatever you are ashamed of, he has covered it.

Think about being one of his willing people. Verse 3 says they offer themselves freely. What is one thing you could offer him freely this week, such as time, money, or an act of service?

And take courage in the final image. Your Lord is not a distant figure who never grew tired. He knows weariness, and he lifts his head in victory.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bow to Jesus as your king and priest forever.
- Thank him for the oath that cannot change.
- Ask him to rule over what resists him in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 118

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."

HEBREWS 1:3

DAY 826 · WEEK 118

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you opened the book of Hebrews and read three Psalms that Hebrews draws on. Take a few moments today to be still before the Son you have been reading about. If you have time, reread Hebrews 1:1-4 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."

HEBREWS 1:3

REST

Meditation

Hebrews 1:3 is the center of the week. In a single sentence, it tells you who Jesus is and what he did.

"The radiance of the glory of God." Light streams from the sun and shares its nature. You cannot have the sun without the light. In the same way, the Son is not a created messenger who tells us about God. He is God's glory shining out. If you want to know what God is like, you look at Jesus.

"The exact imprint of his nature." A seal presses a mark into wax, and the mark reproduces every detail. The Son is the exact expression of the Father's being.

“He upholds the universe by the word of his power.” Everything that exists depends on him right now. The same Jesus who held a child and wept at a tomb is holding the galaxies together.

“After making purification for sins, he sat down.” This is the part most likely to change your week. He sat down. Priests in the old covenant stood daily, offering sacrifices that could never fully remove sin. Christ finished the work. There is nothing left for you to add to it. When you doubt that you are forgiven, remember that the one who made purification is seated, and the work is done.

Say the verse aloud. Carry it with you this week, especially into moments of anxiety. The Son who upholds the universe is the Son who has already dealt with your sin.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began Hebrews, the book that shows how the whole Old Testament points to Christ. You read the opening declaration that God has spoken finally in his Son, and you saw the Son’s superiority over angels. You heard the first warning against drifting, and you watched the Son become human to free us from the fear of death. You read the comparison of Jesus with Moses and the call to enter God’s rest while it is still called today. You saw that Jesus is a great high priest who can sympathize with our weakness, and you read the sober warning in chapter 6 alongside the anchor of God’s oath. In the Psalms, you sang Psalm 95, heard the voice of the Son in Psalm 40, and saw the priest-king of Psalm 110.

Behind it all stands a single truth: the Son is greater than everything that came before him, and he is for you.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

What does it mean to you that God has spoken finally and fully in his Son? Think about how you approach Scripture. Do you read the Old Testament as incomplete or as a story that moves toward Christ? What would change if you read every page as pointing to him?

How does Jesus’ priesthood change the way you approach God in prayer? Hebrews 4:14-16 says he understands your weakness, has passed through the heavens, and invites you to draw near. Think of a specific struggle or failure you have been reluctant to bring to God. What would it look like to bring it to him today, in the name of the priest who knows what it is like to be tempted?

Where are you most tempted to drift, harden your heart, or neglect your salvation? The warnings of Hebrews are meant to keep you close to Christ, not to frighten you away. Name one practice that could help you stay attentive this coming week, and one person who could encourage you in it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the finished work of his Son.

Worship Jesus as the radiance of God's glory.

Rest in all he has done.

DAY 827 · WEEK 119

Hebrews 7:1-28

Melchizedek, the better priest

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 7:1-28, and if you can, reread Genesis 14:17-20 first. The argument here is dense, so read it twice if needed. The core claim is simple: if perfection had been possible through the Levitical priesthood, there would have been no need for another priest to arise.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Last week the author mentioned Melchizedek and then paused to rebuke his readers. Now he returns to the subject and gives it a full chapter. Why does this obscure figure from Genesis matter so much? Because he is the key to understanding how Jesus, who descended from the tribe of Judah and not Levi, can serve as a priest at all. The readers were Jewish Christians who revered the Levitical priesthood as God's own institution. The author does not belittle it. He shows that Scripture itself, in Genesis 14 and Psalm 110, pointed beyond it. This chapter argues that the old priesthood was a temporary shadow, and that the permanent reality has come in Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Melchizedek is "king of righteousness" and "king of peace," king of Salem and priest of God Most High (vv. 1-2).
2. He is described as "without father or mother or genealogy, having neither beginning of days nor end of life, but resembling the Son of God" (v. 3).
3. Abraham gave him a tenth of the spoils, and Melchizedek blessed Abraham. "It is beyond dispute that the inferior is blessed by the superior" (v. 7).
4. Levi, still in the loins of Abraham, paid tithes through him (vv. 9-10).

5. If perfection had come through the Levitical priesthood, why would another priest arise "after the order of Melchizedek" (v. 11)?
6. A change of priesthood requires a change of law (v. 12), and Jesus descended from Judah, a tribe with no priestly role (v. 14).
7. Jesus became a priest "by the power of an indestructible life" and not by ancestry (v. 16).
8. "He always lives to make intercession for them" (v. 25), and he is "holy, innocent, unstained, separated from sinners" (v. 26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This chapter is an exercise in careful Bible reading. The author takes a few verses of Genesis and a single line of Psalm 110 and draws out their full implications. His argument has three steps.

First, Melchizedek is greater than Abraham. Abraham gave him a tenth and received his blessing. In ancient culture, the one who blesses is superior, and the one who tithes is inferior. Since Levi descended from Abraham, the whole Levitical priesthood, in a sense, tithed to Melchizedek in Abraham. So Melchizedek's priesthood has a greater standing than Aaron's.

Second, the very existence of the Melchizedek priest in Psalm 110, centuries after Moses, shows that the Levitical system was incomplete. If the old priesthood could bring perfection, meaning a full and lasting cleansing of conscience and access to God, then no one would have needed to speak of a different priest. But God did speak of one. A new priesthood implies a new law, because the priesthood and the law are tied together. And that is exactly what the new covenant is. The author is not saying the law was bad, but that it was provisional, preparing for something better.

Third, Jesus is that priest. His qualification is not ancestry but "the power of an indestructible life." The Levitical priests died and were replaced, one after another. Jesus lives forever, and therefore his priesthood does not pass to anyone else. Verse 24 says "he holds his priesthood permanently." The practical result is verse 25: "he is able to save to the uttermost those who draw near to God through him, since he always lives to make intercession for them." This is one of the most comforting verses in the New Testament. Uttermost means completely, to the end. The saving power of Christ does not run out, and his intercession does not stop.

What about the description of Melchizedek as having no father, mother, or genealogy? The author is not saying that Melchizedek was a mysterious immortal. He is reading the silence of Genesis. The narrative gives no parentage and records no death. Therefore, as presented in Scripture, he resembles the eternal Son of God. He is a type, a living picture drawn by the Holy Spirit, and the original is Christ.

Verses 26-28 sum it up. We needed a high priest who is holy, innocent, and unstained, who has no need to offer sacrifices for his own sins first, and who offered one sacrifice once for all when he offered up himself. The old priests had to offer for themselves and then for the people, day after day. Jesus did it once, and it was enough.

STEP 5

Connection

The backbone of this chapter is Genesis 14:17-20 and Psalm 110:4. The tithe and blessing look back to Genesis 12:2-3 and forward to the new covenant in Hebrews 8. The Levitical priesthood was established in Exodus 28-29 and Leviticus 8-9. Isaiah 53:12 pictures the Servant who makes intercession for transgressors, and Romans 8:34 gives the same truth about Christ's present ministry.

STEP 6

Application

First, take comfort in "to the uttermost." If you suspect that your sin or weakness is too much for Christ, this verse says otherwise. He saves completely and perpetually.

Second, let the phrase "he always lives to make intercession" shape your prayers. When you do not know what to say, remember that someone is already speaking for you.

Third, notice that Hebrews treats the Old Testament as a book about Christ. Next time you come across a puzzling Old Testament passage, ask: how might this point forward to Jesus? You may not always find the answer, but the question will make you a better reader.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that he is your priest forever and always lives to pray for you.
- Tell him what you need him to intercede for.
- Thank him that he saves you to the uttermost.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 119

“Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God.”

HEBREWS 12:1-2

DAY 828 · WEEK 119

Hebrews 8:1-9:28

The better covenant; the better sacrifice

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 8:1-9:28. This is the theological heart of the letter. Look for the contrast between the earthly tent and the heavenly one, and between the blood of animals and the blood of Christ. Read the quotation of Jeremiah 31:31-34 in 8:8-12 carefully. You encountered it earlier in this plan on the covenant day.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The author has argued that Christ is a priest of a better order. Now he states the main point: we have such a high priest, who is seated in heaven, and he serves in a better sanctuary under a better covenant. This section is where the language of Hebrews becomes most temple-centered, and it can feel unfamiliar. But the author is working with the elements his readers knew well: the tabernacle, the Day of Atonement, and the blood of sacrifices. He shows that these were copies and shadows, and that Christ has entered the reality. This is the heart of how the old covenant fits with the new.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The main point: we have a high priest who is seated at the right hand of the throne in heaven (8:1).
2. The earthly priests serve “a copy and shadow of the heavenly things” (8:5).
3. Christ has obtained a ministry “as much more excellent” as the covenant he mediates is better, “enacted on better promises” (8:6).
4. Jeremiah 31:31-34 is quoted in full, with its promise of a new covenant, laws on hearts, and sins remembered no more (8:8-12).
5. “In speaking of a new covenant, he makes the first one obsolete” (8:13).

6. The first tent had its furnishings, and only the high priest entered the Most Holy Place, once a year, with blood (9:1-7).
7. The Holy Spirit signified that the way into the holy places was not yet opened (9:8).
8. "Without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness of sins" (9:22). Christ appeared "once for all at the end of the ages to put away sin by the sacrifice of himself" (9:26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The language of copy and shadow is crucial. The author does not say the tabernacle was a mistake. It was designed by God, built according to the pattern shown to Moses. But a pattern is not the thing itself. A shadow tells you something real about the object that casts it, but you cannot embrace a shadow. The tabernacle taught Israel that God is holy, that sin is serious, that blood is needed, and that a mediator must stand between God and humanity. All of that was true. But it could not permanently deal with sin.

Chapter 8 then quotes Jeremiah's promise, the longest Old Testament quotation in the New Testament. God says the days are coming when he will make a new covenant. Its features are striking. The law will be written on hearts. Everyone will know the LORD, from the least to the greatest. And God will remember sins no more. The author's comment is quietly devastating: by speaking of a "new" covenant, God has marked the old one as obsolete and ready to vanish. The old covenant did not fail because God failed. Jeremiah 31:32 says Israel broke it. The new covenant is better because it deals with the heart problem that the old one could only expose.

Chapter 9 describes the day of atonement in detail. Once a year, the high priest entered the Most Holy Place carrying blood for himself and the people. The Holy Spirit was teaching something by this arrangement: the way into God's presence was not yet open. The curtain remained. The sacrifices could cleanse the outside, providing ceremonial purity, but they could not clear the conscience.

Then the contrast arrives in verse 11: "But when Christ appeared as a high priest of the good things that have come..." He entered not an earthly tent but the heavenly sanctuary, not with the blood of goats and calves but with his own blood. And he did so once for all, securing an eternal redemption. If the blood of animals could sanctify for the purification of the flesh, how much more will the blood of Christ cleanse our conscience from dead works to serve the living God. The cleansing is deeper because the sacrifice is greater.

The author uses a legal image in verses 16-17. A covenant is like a will. It takes effect when the one who made it dies. Christ's death put the new covenant into effect, and he mediates its promised inheritance to those who are called.

The chapter ends with a striking picture. Humans die once and then face judgment, so Christ was offered once to bear the sins of many, and he will appear a second time, not to deal with sin but to save those who are eagerly waiting for him. The first coming dealt with sin. The second will bring salvation in its fullness.

STEP 5

Connection

This chapter draws on Exodus 25-40, Leviticus 16 (the Day of Atonement), and Jeremiah 31:31-34, which you studied on the covenant day earlier. The blood of the covenant echoes Exodus 24:8, and Jesus used the same language at the Last Supper in Luke 22:20. The "second appearing" links to Acts 1:11, the ascension passage, and to Titus 2:13.

STEP 6

Application

First, let verse 14 reach your conscience. If you still carry guilt over sins God has forgiven, remember that Christ's blood does not just cover the past. It cleanses the conscience. Confess what is true, and then rest in what is done.

Second, notice the promise that God's law is written on hearts. If you have felt that obedience is a burden, ask the Holy Spirit to make God's commands your delight, as he promised.

Third, take comfort in the phrase "once for all." There is no sacrifice left for you to make to earn forgiveness. Serve God because you are cleansed, not to become clean.

Fourth, live in expectation. Christ will appear a second time. Ask yourself how your week would change if you were eagerly waiting for him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the new covenant sealed with the blood of his Son.
- Ask him to cleanse your conscience from dead works.
- Ask him to write his law on your heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 119

“Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God.”

HEBREWS 12:1-2

DAY 829 · WEEK 119

Hebrews 10:1-39

The shadow vs. the reality; the new and living way

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 39 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 10:1-39. Notice the shift from argument to exhortation around verse 19. The first half completes the case that Christ's sacrifice is final. The second half draws three "let us" conclusions for how to live. Pay attention to verses 26-31, which are sobering, and verses 32-39, which are full of encouragement.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The author has spent several chapters building his case for the better priest, better covenant, and better sacrifice. Chapter 10 brings the argument to its climax and then turns on a hinge into the application. The first section returns to the idea of shadow and reality, and the second part invites readers to enter by the new and living way. Throughout, there is a pastoral concern. These Christians had faced hostility and lost property. They were tempted to withdraw. The author wants them to see that the cost of leaving Christ is far greater than the cost of staying.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The law has "a shadow of the good things to come," not the true form of these realities (10:1).
2. If animal sacrifices could cleanse, they would have stopped. Instead they are "a reminder of sins every year" (10:2-3).
3. "It is impossible for the blood of bulls and goats to take away sins" (10:4).
4. Psalm 40:6-8 is quoted as the words of Christ: "a body have you prepared for me… Behold, I have come to do your will, O God" (10:5-7).

5. “By a single offering he has perfected for all time those who are being sanctified” (10:14).
6. We have confidence to enter the holy places by the blood of Jesus, “by the new and living way that he opened for us through the curtain, that is, through his flesh” (10:19-20).
7. Three exhortations follow: “let us draw near,” “let us hold fast,” and “let us consider how to stir up one another to love and good works” (10:22-24).
8. “We are not of those who shrink back and are destroyed, but of those who have faith and preserve their souls” (10:39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening of chapter 10 distills the argument. The law offered a shadow, not the image itself. If the sacrifices of the Day of Atonement could have perfected the worshipers, they would have been offered no more. But the very repetition showed their limitation. Each year the people were reminded of their sins, because the blood of bulls and goats could not take sin away.

Then comes the voice of Christ in Psalm 40. The Son speaks to the Father at the moment of the incarnation: sacrifices and offerings you did not desire, but a body you prepared for me. “Behold, I have come to do your will.” The will of God is that we be sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all. This is the center of the chapter. A body was prepared so that a sacrifice could be made that actually works.

The contrast between the standing priests and the seated Christ is the author’s recurring image. Every priest stands daily, offering the same sacrifices that can never take away sins. But Christ, having offered a single sacrifice for sins for all time, sat down. And because of that single offering, he has perfected for all time those who are being sanctified. Notice the tenses. The perfection is complete, and the sanctification is ongoing. Believers are already fully cleansed in their standing and are still being made holy in their experience. The new covenant promise is repeated: “I will remember their sins and their lawless deeds no more.” And where there is forgiveness, there is no longer any offering for sin.

Now the hinge. Verses 19-25 begin with “therefore” and turn argument into invitation. The curtain that separated humanity from God’s presence has been opened through Christ’s flesh. In the temple, the curtain was torn from top to bottom at the crucifixion (Matthew 27:51), and the author uses this image: the curtain is his flesh. We can enter with confidence,

with hearts sprinkled clean and bodies washed with pure water. The three exhortations follow: draw near in faith, hold fast the confession of hope without wavering, and stir one another up to love and good works, "not neglecting to meet together."

Verses 26-31 are among the most sobering in the New Testament. If we deliberately go on sinning after receiving the knowledge of the truth, no sacrifice remains. The author is describing those who persistently reject Christ and treat his blood as common. To spurn the Son is a more serious offense than breaking the law of Moses. "It is a fearful thing to fall into the hands of the living God." The point is not to undermine assurance but to underline how much is at stake.

But he ends with encouragement. He reminds them of their former courage: they endured a hard struggle, were publicly exposed to reproach, and joyfully accepted the plundering of their property, since they knew they had a better and abiding possession. He tells them not to throw away their confidence. "For you have need of endurance." The one who is coming will come and will not delay. "The righteous shall live by faith." And then comes the closing assurance: "We are not of those who shrink back and are destroyed, but of those who have faith and preserve their souls."

STEP 5

Connection

This chapter quotes Psalm 40 (Day 824), Jeremiah 31 (Day 828), Deuteronomy 32:35-36, and Habakkuk 2:3-4. The "new and living way" through the curtain links to Exodus 26:31-33, where the veil separated the holy place from the most holy place, and to the tearing of the veil in Matthew 27:51. Paul quotes Habakkuk 2:4 in Romans 1:17 and Galatians 3:11. The call to meet together prepares for the next day's doctrinal reading.

STEP 6

Application

First, accept the invitation. You have confidence to enter God's presence by the blood of Jesus. If you have been treating prayer as a duty or a risk, remember that the way is open.

Second, examine your commitment to gathering with the church. Verse 25 does not treat attendance as optional. Ask who in your church needs your encouragement, and make a plan to talk to them this week.

Third, think about endurance. The original readers had lost property for Christ. What have you been willing to lose? What have you been unwilling to risk? Ask the Lord for courage.

Fourth, take verse 38 as a daily motto: the righteous shall live by faith.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for opening the way through the curtain by his body.

Draw near with a true heart in full assurance, and tell him so.

Ask him to help you hold fast and encourage others.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 119

"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God."

HEBREWS 12:1-2

DAY 830 · WEEK 119

Acts 2:42-47; Hebrews 10:24-25

Covenanted community

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Doctrine · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 2:42-47 and Hebrews 10:24-25. These two short passages describe the same reality from different angles: the first shows what a gathered church looked like in the days after Pentecost, and the second urges believers to keep meeting. Read them together and ask: what does it mean to belong to a church, not just to attend one?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday's reading ended with an exhortation that tends to be passed over quickly: "not neglecting to meet together, as is the habit of some." Today we pause to think about what that means. Many new believers assume Christianity is primarily a private relationship with God, and that church is a helpful extra. The Bible does not present it that way. From the first day of the church's life, those who believed were devoted to a community. The people of the new covenant are a family, a body, and a household. This pause examines the biblical basis for committed membership in a local church.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The first Christians "devoted themselves to the apostles" teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers' (Acts 2:42).
2. They had "all things in common" and sold possessions to give to anyone in need (2:44-45).
3. They met "day by day," both in the temple and in homes (2:46).
4. The Lord added to their number "day by day those who were being saved" (2:47). Salvation and community are joined.

5. Hebrews 10:24 says to "consider how to stir up one another to love and good works." The verb is intentional and active.
6. Verse 25 warns against "neglecting to meet together, as is the habit of some." Even in the first century, some were drifting away.
7. The motivation is eschatological: "as you see the Day drawing near."
8. Both passages assume a visible, identifiable community. Someone could be "added" to it and someone could "neglect" it.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

A local church is a gathered community of baptized believers who have covenanted together to worship God, hear his word, observe the ordinances, encourage one another, and carry out the mission of Christ in a particular place. Membership in such a church is how a Christian visibly and formally commits to the body of Christ.

The New Testament does not use the exact phrase "church membership," but it describes the reality. In the book of Acts, believers are "added" to the church (2:41, 47). Some in Jerusalem "joined" the disciples, and others "dared not join them" (5:13). In 1 Corinthians 5, Paul tells the church to remove an unrepentant man from their fellowship, which presupposes a recognizable body with a boundary. In 2 Corinthians 2:6, Paul speaks of a punishment "by the majority." In Hebrews 13:17, believers are told to obey and submit to their leaders, "for they are keeping watch over your souls." You cannot be accountable to leaders you do not know or follow leaders you have not identified. Peter says the elders are to shepherd "the flock of God that is among you" (1 Peter 5:2). A flock has a defined membership.

Why does it matter? First, because Christ loves the church. Ephesians 5:25 says he "gave himself up for her." To neglect the church is to neglect the bride of Christ. Second, because the Christian life is lived in community. The New Testament is full of "one another" commands: love one another, bear one another's burdens, forgive one another, teach and admonish one another, confess your sins to one another, and encourage one another. These commands cannot be obeyed alone. Third, because God gave us spiritual gifts for the common good (1 Corinthians 12:7). If you are not part of a body, your gifts go unused and others miss what God intended for them. Fourth, because the church exercises discipline and gives assurance. Jesus gave the church authority in Matthew 16 and 18 to affirm credible professions of faith and to correct those who stray. Baptism and the Lord's Supper are practiced within the church. Finally, because a committed church is a witness to the world. Jesus said in John 13:35, "By this all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another."

What should membership look like? A member commits to regular attendance and participation, to supporting the church with time, gifts, and money, to submitting to the leadership and the discipline of the church, to pursuing peace and unity, and to serving others. The church, in turn, commits to teach, pray for, care for, and shepherd its members. This is a covenant, and it echoes the covenants that have run throughout the Bible.

A few cautions are in order. No church is perfect, and joining one means joining a community of imperfect people. Some have been wounded by churches, and that grief is real. But the answer is to find a healthy church, one that preaches the gospel faithfully, practices the ordinances rightly, and cares for its members. Membership is not a requirement for salvation. It is the fruit of salvation and the normal setting of Christian growth.

A final word to those who feel they can follow Jesus privately. Scripture knows no solitary Christians. When God saves a person, he adds them to a body. The hand cannot say to the foot, "I have no need of you" (1 Corinthians 12:21). And the Christian who drifts from the gathering is at risk, because we are not designed to persevere alone.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Acts 2 gives us a picture of the church in its earliest and freshest form. After Pentecost, three thousand people were baptized and added. The text immediately describes what they did: they devoted themselves. The verb implies persistence and commitment, not a casual drop-in. Four things marked them: teaching, fellowship, the breaking of bread, and prayer. These are the basic activities of a church in every age.

The fellowship described in the passage was practical. They shared what they had. They saw a need, and they met it. This was not a forced system but a spontaneous generosity that grew from the gospel. They met both in the temple courts and from house to house. The large gatherings and the small gatherings were both necessary. They ate with glad and generous hearts, praising God. And the result was that outsiders were drawn in, and "the Lord added to their number day by day those who were being saved."

Hebrews 10:24-25 addresses the same church a generation later, when the early enthusiasm was fading. Some were neglecting to meet. Perhaps because of persecution, or fatigue, or doubt. The author's response is not a rebuke of those individuals but a call to the community. "Consider how to stir up one another." The word "stir up" is literally "provoke," and it is used elsewhere for sharp irritation. Here it is used positively: we are to provoke one another to love and good works. That requires being close enough to know what the other person needs.

The author gives the reason: “as you see the Day drawing near.” The more the return of Christ approaches, the more believers should gather, not less. The temptation in hard times is to withdraw. The biblical answer is to draw closer.

It is worth noticing that these two passages answer two different objections. Acts 2 answers the person who says, “I can worship God just as well on my own.” The earliest believers did not think of discipleship as a solo project. Everything they were devoted to, the teaching, the meals, the prayers, and the sharing of possessions, required other people. Hebrews 10 answers a different objection: “I’ve been hurt, tired, or disappointed, so I’ll step back for a while.” The author does not deny that the Christian life is hard. He says that the answer to hardship is more community, because a believer who is isolated is vulnerable to the “deceitfulness of sin” (3:13) in a way that a believer surrounded by brothers and sisters is not.

Notice also what the gathering is for. It is not first about the programs or the building. Acts 2 centers on the apostles’ teaching, so the word of God sits at the heart. It includes the Lord’s Supper (“the breaking of bread”), where Christ’s sacrifice is proclaimed. It includes prayer. In other words, the church gathers around Christ and his gospel. Hebrews 10 puts the gathering inside a larger argument about Christ’s priesthood. We meet because we have a great high priest, because the curtain is open, and because we need each other to keep holding fast. The church is where the new covenant becomes visible. Membership is not an add-on to the gospel. It is the shape of life together under the gospel.

STEP 5

Connection

The church as a covenant community extends the covenant structure studied earlier in this plan. Israel was the assembly (qahal) of the LORD, and the church is the assembly of the new covenant (Hebrews 12:22-24). The body language of 1 Corinthians 12 and Romans 12, the household language of Ephesians 2:19 and 1 Timothy 3:15, and the shepherding language of 1 Peter 5 all assume a defined community. Matthew 18:15-20 describes the church’s authority, and Acts 20:28 charges elders to care for the flock.

STEP 6

Application

If you are not yet a member of a local church, consider this week how to take the next step. Talk to the pastor or a leader about what membership involves. If you are a member, ask whether you are living out your commitment. Do you attend regularly? Do you serve? Do you know others well enough to encourage them?

Choose one person in your church to stir up this week. Send a message, offer to meet, or invite them to a meal. Ask how you can pray for them. This is how the "one another" commands get lived out.

If you have been hurt by a church, bring that pain honestly to the Lord. He loves his church, and he can heal what has been broken. Pray for a community where you can be known and loved.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for loving his church and giving himself for her.

Ask him to make you a faithful member who meets with his people.

Ask him to show you how to encourage someone this week.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 119

"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God."

HEBREWS 12:1-2

DAY 831 · WEEK 119

Hebrews 11:1-40

Faith's hall of fame

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 40 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 11:1-40. This chapter is often called the "hall of faith," and it is worth reading it as a story rather than a list. Notice how each person acts on a promise they cannot yet see. As you read, pay attention to how the chapter begins with a definition and ends with a surprise: none of them received what was promised.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The last chapter ended with a call to endurance: "the righteous shall live by faith." Chapter 11 is the author's answer to the question, what does that look like? He walks through the Old Testament, and the people you have been reading about in this plan appear one after another: Abel, Enoch, Noah, Abraham, Sarah, Isaac, Jacob, Joseph, Moses, Rahab, and many more. Their stories are different, but their faith has the same shape. They believed God's word about what he would do, and they lived accordingly. For readers who were tired and tempted to quit, this was a gallery of encouragement. For us, it is a review of much of the Old Testament through the lens of faith.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Faith is the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen" (11:1).
2. "By faith we understand that the universe was created by the word of God" (11:3).
3. Abel, Enoch, and Noah are praised for worship, walking with God, and obedience on the basis of a warning about what was not yet seen (11:4-7).
4. Abraham went out "not knowing where he was going" and lived as a sojourner in tents (11:8-10).

5. These all "died in faith, not having received the things promised, but having seen them and greeted them from afar" (11:13).
6. They desired "a better country, that is, a heavenly one," and God "has prepared for them a city" (11:16).
7. Verses 32-38 list others whose faith led to victory and others whose faith led to suffering, torture, and exile.
8. "God had provided something better for us, that apart from us they should not be made perfect" (11:40).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter begins with a definition. Faith is the assurance of things hoped for and the conviction of things not seen. It is not a leap in the dark or wishful thinking. It is confidence in what God has said, which stands on his character and promise. Faith gives substance to what is hoped for and evidence for what cannot yet be seen.

The author illustrates this with an extended survey. Some things stand out. First, faith always responds to a word. Noah heard a warning. Abraham heard a call. Moses heard a promise. Faith is not generated from within. It is a response to God speaking. Second, faith acts. Abel offered. Noah built. Abraham went. Sarah considered him faithful who had promised. Faith is not merely inward conviction. It is obedience.

Third, faith endures. Notice verses 13-16. These people lived as strangers and exiles on the earth. They could have returned to the land they left, but they desired a better country. Because of that, "God is not ashamed to be called their God." Faith is not fully satisfied by this world. It looks for a city with foundations, whose designer and builder is God.

The most remarkable examples come in verses 17-19. Abraham, when tested, offered up Isaac, "considering that God was able even to raise him from the dead." You read this in Genesis 22. The author reveals what was going on in Abraham's mind: he believed in resurrection before it happened. That is the kind of faith that makes sense of an impossible command.

Verses 32-38 are striking. The author, running short of time, summarizes: some by faith conquered kingdoms, shut the mouths of lions, and escaped the edge of the sword. Others by faith were tortured, mocked, imprisoned, and killed. "Of whom the world was not worthy." Both groups are commended for faith. Faith is not a guarantee of success or comfort. Sometimes it leads to victory in this life, and sometimes to suffering. In either case, God honors it.

Then comes the surprise. “And all these, though commended through their faith, did not receive what was promised, since God had provided something better for us.” The Old Testament saints waited, and we are living in the fulfillment of what they longed for. Christ has come. And they will not be made perfect without us. The family of faith is one, and its completion awaits all of God’s people together.

This is the proper way to read the chapter. It does not tell you to be like the heroes. It tells you that God was faithful to them, and that he will be faithful to you. The “cloud of witnesses” in the next chapter will be exactly these people, and they are cheering for you to run the race that they have finished.

STEP 5

Connection

Nearly every person in this chapter appears in the Old Testament stories you have read in this plan: Genesis 4 (Abel), Genesis 5 (Enoch), Genesis 6-9 (Noah), Genesis 12-22 (Abraham and Sarah), Genesis 27-50 (Isaac, Jacob, Joseph), and Exodus (Moses). The definition of faith recalls Genesis 15:6. The better country anticipates Revelation 21-22. The unnamed sufferers of verses 35-38 recall the prophets and the Maccabean martyrs, and the idea of God’s people waiting for the whole body to be completed anticipates Revelation 6:9-11.

STEP 6

Application

First, think about how you define faith. If you think of it as a feeling or a general positive attitude, let this chapter correct you. Faith is trusting what God has said and acting on it.

Second, identify one area where God has given you a clear word, in Scripture, but you have not yet acted. It might be forgiving someone, giving generously, or sharing the gospel. Take one concrete step.

Third, be encouraged that faith does not always bring ease. If you are suffering and wondering whether you are doing something wrong, notice the second half of the list. Faithful people suffered too. God was not ashamed of them.

Fourth, look at the “better” in verse 40. We have received what they longed for. Thank God that you live on this side of the cross.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God for faith that trusts his word when you cannot see the outcome.

Name a person from the chapter whose faith you want to follow.

Thank him that they all point to Jesus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 119

"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God."

HEBREWS 12:1-2

DAY 832 · WEEK 119

Hebrews 12:1-29

Run the race; Mount Zion; the discipline of God

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 29 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 12:1-29. Chapter 12 begins with the image of a race and ends with a vision of the heavenly Jerusalem. Pay attention to the word "therefore" in verse 1 and to the contrast between Mount Sinai and Mount Zion in verses 18-24. Notice also how the discipline of the Father is presented as love and not rejection.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The great chapter on faith led to a great crowd of witnesses, and now the author brings the argument home with a series of commands. These Christians are tired and discouraged, and they have faced hardship. The author does not offer a quick fix. Instead, he gives them three things: a model to follow in Jesus, a perspective on suffering as the discipline of a loving Father, and a vision of where they are going. The chapter ends with a sober reminder that the God who spoke at Sinai still speaks, and that he is a consuming fire.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us also lay aside every weight, and sin which clings so closely" (12:1).
2. "Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith" (12:1-2).
3. Jesus endured the cross "for the joy that was set before him," despising the shame, and is seated at God's right hand (12:2).
4. Readers are told to "consider him who endured from sinners such hostility against himself, so that you may not grow weary or fainthearted" (12:3).
5. Proverbs 3:11-12 is quoted: "the Lord disciplines the one he loves" (12:5-6).

6. God disciplines us “for our good, that we may share his holiness” (12:10).
7. Mount Sinai (fear, fire, trembling) is contrasted with Mount Zion (the heavenly Jerusalem, angels, the church of the firstborn, Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant) (12:18-24).
8. “Our God is a consuming fire,” and we are receiving “a kingdom that cannot be shaken” (12:28-29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The race image is familiar, but the details matter. The race is not a sprint but a long endurance run. Runners strip off whatever slows them. Hebrews names two things: weights and sin. A weight is not necessarily sinful. It may be a good thing that hinders you. Sin is the thing that clings so closely, and it is to be put off entirely. Both must go if the race is to be run well.

The center of the passage is verse 2. We run “looking to Jesus.” The Greek verb means to fix your eyes, to look away from everything else. He is the founder (the pioneer, the one who blazed the trail) and the perfecter (the one who brings it to completion) of our faith. He is not only an example of faith but the source and goal of it. And what did he do? He endured the cross for the joy set before him. Joy and cross are not contradictory. The cross was the path to the joy of redeeming his people and sitting at the Father’s right hand. He despised the shame, meaning he counted it as nothing compared to the joy. This is why we can endure: the one who ran first has finished and is waiting.

Then the author addresses the problem of suffering. The readers had suffered, but not unto blood. He reaches for Proverbs 3 and reminds them that they are sons. Discipline is a sign of a father’s love. This word “discipline” is not just punishment but training, the whole process of upbringing. A father who does not discipline his children shows indifference. God disciplines us “for our good, that we may share his holiness.” It is painful at the moment, but it yields “the peaceful fruit of righteousness to those who have been trained by it.” Notice that this does not say all suffering is punishment for specific sins. It says that God uses hardship for our growth.

The final half of the chapter contrasts two mountains. At Sinai, the people trembled. There was darkness, gloom, and a voice so terrifying that they begged not to hear it. Even Moses said, “I tremble with fear.” But the Christian has not come to Sinai. We have come to Mount Zion, the city of the living God, with innumerable angels in festal gathering, the assembly of the firstborn, God the judge of all, the spirits of the righteous made perfect, and Jesus, the

mediator of a new covenant, and the sprinkled blood that speaks a better word than the blood of Abel. Abel's blood cried out for vengeance, and Christ's blood cries out for forgiveness.

Yet the author does not let the contrast lull anyone into complacency. "See that you do not refuse him who is speaking." If Israel did not escape when they refused the one who warned on earth, how much less will we escape if we reject the one who warns from heaven? The shaking of heaven and earth will remove everything temporary, and only what is unshakable will remain. We are receiving that kingdom. Therefore, let us offer worship with reverence and awe, "for our God is a consuming fire."

STEP 5

Connection

Abel appears in Genesis 4 and again in 11:4. Sinai's terrors are described in Exodus 19-20 and Deuteronomy 4-5. The shaking of the heavens and earth is from Haggai 2:6. Proverbs 3:11-12 supplies the discipline text. The "heavenly Jerusalem" anticipates Revelation 21, and the "consuming fire" comes from Deuteronomy 4:24. You read Psalm 95 earlier this week, and its warning against refusing God's voice stands behind verse 25.

STEP 6

Application

First, ask what weights and sins are slowing your race. A weight might be a habit, a relationship, or a pursuit that is not wrong in itself but is dulling your devotion. Name one thing to lay aside this week.

Second, when you grow weary, fix your eyes on Jesus. Read one of the Gospel accounts of the cross and consider what he endured for you.

Third, reread a current hardship through the lens of verse 6. If you are in a season of difficulty, ask what God might be teaching you. You may not know. But trust that he does not waste suffering.

Fourth, worship with reverence. The God who welcomes you is also the God who is a consuming fire. Let that shape how you come into church this Sunday.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you run the race with endurance, eyes on Jesus.

Tell him what weight or sin you need to lay aside.

Thank him for his discipline as a Father.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 119

"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God."

HEBREWS 12:1-2

DAY 833 · WEEK 119

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you read the heart of Hebrews, the better priest, the better covenant, and the better sacrifice, followed by the call to faith and endurance. If you have time, reread Hebrews 12:1-3 slowly. Let it be a rest for your eyes, and let them settle on Jesus.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God."

HEBREWS 12:1-2

REST

Meditation

Hebrews 12:1-2 gathers the week into one picture. After chapters of argument about priests and sacrifices, the author puts you on the track and tells you where to look.

"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us." The race is set before you. God has not asked you to run someone else's course. He has placed you where you are. And the race requires endurance, because it is long.

"Looking to Jesus." The whole letter has been building to this. After describing his deity, his humanity, his priesthood, his covenant, and his sacrifice, the author says: look at him. When you are tired, look at him. When you are tempted, look at him. When you have failed, look at him.

“The founder and perfecter of our faith.” He started your faith, and he will finish it. You are not trusting in the strength of your own commitment. The one who began a good work in you will bring it to completion.

“For the joy that was set before him endured the cross.” He knew what lay ahead. The cross was real agony, and the joy was real too, because the joy was you. He saw the family he was gaining and he endured.

“And is seated at the right hand.” Again he sits. The race has been run, and the victory has been won. Say the verse aloud a few times today. When fatigue comes this week, let it send you to Jesus.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week brought you to the center of the book of Hebrews. You read about Melchizedek, the priest-king, and saw why the order of Aaron could never be final. You read about the better covenant that Jeremiah promised and the better sacrifice that Christ offered once for all. You saw the shadow and the reality side by side, and you heard the invitation to enter by the new and living way. You paused to consider the local church and what it means to be covenanted with a body of believers. You walked through the great chapter on faith, from Abel to the unnamed martyrs, and saw that all of them were waiting for something better. And you ended with a call to run with endurance, looking to Jesus, who is the founder and perfecter of faith.

The week’s message is simple. Everything the Old Testament pointed toward, Christ has done. You can come with confidence, you can endure with hope, and you can look to him.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

What does “once for all” mean for you personally? Hebrews says Christ’s sacrifice is complete and cannot be repeated or improved. Where do you still try to earn God’s approval, through performance, guilt, or striving? What would it look like to rest in a finished work?

How does Hebrews 12:2 change the way you think about suffering? Jesus endured the cross for the joy set before him. He knew what was on the other side. Think of a current difficulty. How might it look different if you saw it through the lens of the Savior who endured and is now seated in victory? What does it mean for you to look to him?

Who are the people in your life who stir you up to love and good works? Think of one person who encourages your faith, and one person you could encourage. Consider writing a note or sending a message today to say thank you or to offer prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for offering a single sacrifice for sins and sitting down.

Rest in his finished work.

Tell him what you are trying to earn that he has already finished.

DAY 834 · WEEK 120

Hebrews 13:1-25

Love, hospitality, and Jesus, the same yesterday and today

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 25 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 13:1-25. After twelve chapters of argument and exhortation, the letter ends with a series of practical commands and a closing benediction. Read it as a picture of what the Christian life looks like when it flows from the finished work of Christ. Pay special attention to verse 8 and verses 20-21.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The author has been building toward a conclusion for twelve chapters. Now, in the closing chapter, the theology becomes concrete. If Christ is greater than angels, Moses, and the priests, if his sacrifice is finished, and if we have a kingdom that cannot be shaken, how should we live? The answer is surprisingly down to earth: love one another, show hospitality, honor marriage, be content with what you have, remember your leaders, and offer praise and good works as sacrifices. The letter ends with one of the most beautiful benedictions in the Bible. The shape of the chapter teaches us that doctrine is meant to produce love.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Let brotherly love continue. Do not neglect to show hospitality to strangers, for thereby some have entertained angels unawares” (13:1-2).
2. Believers are to remember those in prison and those who are mistreated, “since you also are in the body” (13:3).
3. “Let marriage be held in honor among all, and let the marriage bed be undefiled” (13:4).
4. “Keep your life free from love of money, and be content with what you have, for he has said, ‘I will never leave you nor forsake you’” (13:5).
5. “Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever” (13:8).

6. “Let us go to him outside the camp and bear the reproach he endured” (13:13). Christ suffered outside the gate.

7. “Through him then let us continually offer up a sacrifice of praise to God” and do not neglect to do good and share (13:15-16).

8. The closing prayer asks the “God of peace” who brought again from the dead “our Lord Jesus, the great shepherd of the sheep” to equip you with everything good to do his will (13:20-21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The commands of chapter 13 are brief, and each one is rooted in the gospel. Brotherly love is the first. The word is philadelphia, the love of siblings. If Christ has made us family, we are to treat each other as family. Hospitality follows. The example of entertaining angels unawares recalls Abraham in Genesis 18 and Lot in Genesis 19. We never know who is at the door.

The call to remember prisoners is a call to empathy. Many in the original audience had experienced imprisonment, and the author asks them to identify with others who suffer. Marriage is honored. Contentment is the answer to the love of money, and the reason is not “because you have enough” but because “he has said, I will never leave you nor forsake you.” This is a quotation from Deuteronomy 31:6 and Joshua 1:5. The presence of God is the deepest provision. So we can say with confidence, “The Lord is my helper; I will not fear; what can man do to me?”

Verse 8 stands out like a single stone in a wall: “Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever.” The context is a warning against “diverse and strange teachings” (v. 9). Fads come and go, but Christ does not change. He is the same one that Abraham and Moses looked toward, and he is the same one who intercedes for us now, and he will be the same when he returns. His character is as reliable as his promise.

The next section (vv. 10-16) returns to the language of sacrifice. Jesus suffered outside the gate, like the bodies of the sin offerings burned outside the camp. The author calls the readers to join him there. This means bearing reproach, being willing to leave the comfort of what is socially acceptable and the old religious structures. “For here we have no lasting city, but we seek the city that is to come.” We are pilgrims. Yet there are still sacrifices we offer. Not for atonement, since that is finished, but sacrifices of praise, doing good, and sharing. “With such sacrifices God is pleased.”

The leaders of the church are to be remembered and obeyed. They keep watch over souls and will give an account. The author asks for prayer, and then he pronounces the benediction. “Now may the God of peace who brought again from the dead our Lord Jesus,

the great shepherd of the sheep, by the blood of the eternal covenant, equip you with everything good that you may do his will." This single sentence contains the whole letter in miniature: God, peace, resurrection, shepherd, blood, covenant, and equipping. The one who has done the work for us will also work in us. He equips us to do his will, working in us "that which is pleasing in his sight, through Jesus Christ." The glory belongs to him forever.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 13:2 recalls Genesis 18-19. The promise of presence quotes Deuteronomy 31:6 and Joshua 1:5, and the confession of verse 6 quotes Psalm 118:6. The sin offering burned outside the camp comes from Leviticus 16:27. The "great shepherd" echoes Isaiah 63:11, Ezekiel 34, Psalm 23, and John 10, and "the blood of the eternal covenant" recalls Zechariah 9:11 and Jeremiah 32:40. The benediction ties the letter to the Old Testament hope of peace and the shepherd-king.

STEP 6

Application

First, choose one practical command from this chapter to act on this week. Welcome a stranger, visit or write to someone who is suffering, honor your marriage or encourage someone in theirs, or practice contentment by giving something away.

Second, memorize verse 5. When you are anxious about money or the future, replace the worry with God's promise: "I will never leave you nor forsake you."

Third, pray for your pastors and church leaders by name. Ask how you could make their work a joy and not a burden.

Fourth, rest in verse 8. Whatever is changing in your life, the Savior is the same. Consider writing the verse where you will see it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that Jesus is the same yesterday, today, and forever.

Ask him to equip you with everything good to do his will.

Ask him to help you love and show hospitality.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 120

“But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves.”

JAMES 1:22

DAY 835 · WEEK 120

Psalm 22

My God, my God, the psalm Hebrews draws from

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Psalm · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 22 slowly, in two sittings if needed. The first twenty-one verses are a cry of anguish, and the last ten are a shout of praise. The psalm is quoted or alluded to by Hebrews, Matthew, Mark, John, and Paul. As you read, think of Jesus on the cross, because his own words from the cross are the opening line.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 22 is one of the most important psalms in the Bible and one of the most poignant. David wrote it, but he writes with details that go beyond anything that happened to him. As you read, you will find a description of crucifixion centuries before it was invented. Jesus quoted the first line while hanging on the cross, and the Gospel writers echo it in the details they record. The author of Hebrews also draws from this psalm. In Hebrews 2:12, the Son says to the Father, "I will tell of your name to my brothers; in the midst of the congregation I will sing your praise," quoting Psalm 22:22. We close the unit with this psalm because it shows the cost of the salvation Hebrews has described and the triumph that follows.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (v. 1). Jesus quoted this on the cross (Matthew 27:46).
2. David trusts that God is holy and was faithful to the fathers who cried out and were delivered (vv. 3-5).
3. "But I am a worm and not a man, scorned by mankind and despised by the people" (v. 6).

4. Mockers say, “He trusts in the LORD; let him deliver him” (v. 8), the same words the leaders used at the cross (Matthew 27:43).
5. “They have pierced my hands and feet” (v. 16). The bones are out of joint, the tongue sticks to the jaws, and they divide his garments by lot (vv. 14-18).
6. At verse 22, the psalm turns: “I will tell of your name to my brothers; in the midst of the congregation I will praise you.”
7. God “has not despised or abhorred the affliction of the afflicted” (v. 24).
8. The psalm ends with the whole earth turning to the LORD and a people yet unborn hearing “that he has done it” (vv. 27-31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with the cry of a person who feels abandoned by God. “Why have you forsaken me?” The question is honest, and the psalm does not rush to resolve it. David describes the experience of suffering with God’s apparent silence. He cries day and night, and there is no answer.

Yet even in the dark, David does not let go of God. “Yet you are holy” (v. 3). The word “yet” is the hinge of the first section. His present experience says God has left, but his history says God does not abandon those who trust him. The fathers cried and were delivered. So he continues to cry.

Verses 6-21 are a vivid, almost cinematic description of suffering. David describes himself as a worm, scorned and mocked. People gather like bulls and lions and dogs. His strength is poured out like water, his heart melts like wax, and his tongue sticks to his jaws. They have pierced his hands and feet. They divide his garments. No known event in David’s life matches these details. They fit the crucifixion exactly. Christ on the cross experienced what David described: the mockery, the thirst, the pierced hands, and the soldiers casting lots for his clothing. The psalm is a Spirit-given portrait of the Messiah’s sufferings, and it was written about a thousand years before they happened.

When Jesus cried “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”, he was not only expressing pain. He was identifying with the entire psalm. He took on himself the experience of being forsaken so that we never will be. The wrath that should have fallen on us fell on him, and in that moment he experienced the separation from the Father that sin deserves. This is the mystery of the atonement, and it is the reason the author of Hebrews can say that Christ’s sacrifice is enough.

Then the psalm turns in verse 22, and the tone changes entirely. The sufferer is rescued. “You have answered me.” And now he promises to declare God’s name to his brothers and praise him in the congregation. This is the resurrection, which is the Father’s answer to the cry. Hebrews 2:12 puts these words in the mouth of the risen Christ, who stands among his people and leads their worship. And the effect reaches to the ends of the earth. “All the ends of the earth shall remember and turn to the LORD.” A people yet unborn, including us, will be told of what he has done. The final word of the psalm is that “he has done it.” This is the Hebrew equivalent of “It is finished.”

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 22 is quoted or echoed throughout the crucifixion narratives: Matthew 27:35-46, Mark 15:24-34, Luke 23:34, and John 19:23-24. Hebrews 2:12 quotes verse 22. The suffering servant of Isaiah 53 parallels this psalm. The final verses link to the Abrahamic promise of blessing for all nations (Genesis 12:3) and to the Great Commission in Matthew 28.

STEP 6

Application

First, let this psalm give you language for your own darkest moments. If you have ever felt abandoned by God, you are not the first. The psalm models honest crying out and a refusal to let go of God’s character.

Second, consider what Jesus did for you. He was forsaken so that you will never be. When you feel alone, remember that your Savior has been there and has made a way for you to be accepted.

Third, take the praise section seriously. David vows to tell others of God’s deliverance. Who could you tell this week about what Christ has done?

Fourth, spend some time in silent gratitude. The one who suffered this was your substitute.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being forsaken in your place.
- Thank God that he did not hide his face.
- Praise him for the great congregation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 120

“But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves.”

JAMES 1:22

DAY 836 · WEEK 120

Review and Reflection

Unit 23 review, The Better Covenant, Hebrews

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but one who in every respect has been tempted as we are, yet without sin. Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace, that we may receive mercy and find grace to help in time of need."
>
> HEBREWS 4:15-16

REST

Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and reflection on what you have learned in Unit 23.

Begin by memorizing the verse above if you have not already. Hebrews 4:15-16 is the gospel for the weary believer. It tells you three things about Jesus and one thing about you.

First, Jesus sympathizes. He is not a high priest who looks down at weakness with disdain. He has felt hunger, grief, exhaustion, betrayal, and temptation. When you come to him, you are coming to someone who understands.

Second, Jesus is without sin. He was tempted in every respect, yet he did not fall. This is why his sympathy is not that of someone who gave in. He felt the full force of temptation, more than any of us, because he never gave way. And because he is sinless, his sacrifice is acceptable and his priesthood is effective.

Third, Jesus sits on a throne of grace. The throne is the seat of a king and of a judge. But for those who are in Christ, it is a throne of grace. The one who sits there has already paid for our sins.

And the verse gives you your part: draw near with confidence. Not with arrogance, not with a sense of deserving, but with boldness that rests entirely on him. You will receive mercy for what you have done and find grace to help in time of need. Say it aloud. Carry it with you into every need this week.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 23 you have traveled through the whole book of Hebrews, the sermon that shows how Christ fulfills everything the Old Testament promised. It began with a majestic sentence: God has spoken finally and fully through his Son, the radiance of God's glory and the exact imprint of his nature. You saw that the Son is greater than the angels, who mediated the law, and that he became human to free us from the fear of death. You read the comparison with Moses, the warning from Psalm 95 against hardening our hearts, and the promise of a Sabbath rest that remains for God's people.

You came to the center of the book: Jesus is the great high priest who sympathizes with our weaknesses, who passed through the heavens, and who invites us to draw near to the throne of grace. You read the warning in chapter 6 and the anchor of God's oath. You saw Melchizedek, the priest-king of Genesis 14, as the pattern for a priesthood that never ends. You read the better covenant promised in Jeremiah 31, the better sanctuary, and the better sacrifice. The blood of bulls and goats could not remove sin, but the blood of Christ has cleansed the conscience once for all, and the curtain has been opened by his flesh.

Along the way you paused to consider the Ascension, where Christ was enthroned at God's right hand and began his priestly ministry of intercession, and the doctrine of church membership, where Hebrews 10:24-25 calls us to gather and stir one another up. You studied Psalms 95, 40, 110, and 22, each of which Hebrews draws on to show the voice of the Son. You walked through the hall of faith in chapter 11, where all of God's people lived by promises they only saw from afar, and you heard the call in chapter 12 to run the race, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith. Finally, you read the practical commands of chapter 13 and the benediction that sums up the book: the God of peace, who raised the great shepherd by the blood of the eternal covenant, equips us for his will.

The message of Hebrews can be stated in one sentence: Jesus is better, so hold fast to him.

REFLECT

Review Questions

How does Hebrews demonstrate that Jesus is better than angels, Moses, and the Levitical priesthood?

Look back over chapters 1 to 7. Choose one comparison (Christ and the angels, Moses, or the Levitical priests) and explain in your own words why he is better. How does this help you trust him more fully?

What is the relationship between the Old Covenant and the New Covenant?

Reread Hebrews 8:1-13 and 10:1-18. List two things the old covenant could not do and two things the new covenant does. Which of these matters most to you today?

What does it mean that Christ is our high priest after the order of Melchizedek?

Consider Genesis 14, Psalm 110, and Hebrews 5 to 7. Why does it matter that Jesus is both king and priest, and that his priesthood never ends? Write a few sentences on what this means for your prayers.

What does Hebrews 11 teach us about the nature of faith, and how does it point us to Christ?

Reread Hebrews 11:1-3, 11:39-40, and 12:1-2. In your own words, what is faith, according to this chapter? Name one person from the chapter whose faith you want to follow, and say how each of them points to Jesus.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the book of Hebrews and for the Son it reveals.

Tell him which comparison of Christ meant the most to you.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 24 · DAYS 837-865

Faith Lived Out: General Epistles

James, 1-2 Peter, 1-3 John, Jude

What does genuine faith look like in real life? Holiness, love, suffering, perseverance.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"We love because he first loved us."

1 JOHN 4:19

Speech, integrity, and the cornerstone (12, 15, 24, 34, 118:1-18, 31:1-8) beside the General Epistles.

UNIT 24

In this unit

WEEK 120

837	James 1:1-27	*Reading*
838	James 2:1-26	*Reading*
839	James 2:14-26; Hebrews 11:1-6	*Doctrine*
840	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 121

841	James 3:1-4:17	*Reading*
842	James 5:1-20	*Reading*
843	Psalm 12	*Psalm*
844	Psalm 15	*Psalm*
845	Psalm 24	*Psalm*
846	1 Peter 1:1-2:12	*Reading*
847	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 122

848	1 Peter 2:13-3:22	*Reading*
849	1 Peter 4:1-5:14	*Reading*
850	2 Peter 1:1-21	*Reading*
851	2 Peter 1:16-21; 2 Peter 3:15-16	*Doctrine*
852	2 Peter 2:1-3:18	*Reading*
853	Psalm 34	*Psalm*
854	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 123

855	Psalm 118:1-18	*Psalm*
856	Psalm 31:1-8	*Psalm*
857	1 John 1:1-2:29	*Reading*
858	1 John 3:1-24	*Reading*

859	1 John 4:1-5:21	*Reading*
860	John 10:27-30; Romans 8:31-39; 1 John 5:11-13	*Doctrine*
861	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 124

862	2 John 1:1-13	*Reading*
863	3 John 1:1-14	*Reading*
864	Jude 1:1-25	*Reading*
865	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 837 · WEEK 120

James 1:1-27

Trials; temptation; hearing and doing

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 27 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read James 1:1-27. James writes to Jewish Christians scattered abroad, and the letter reads like a collection of wisdom sayings. Notice how trials, temptation, and the word of God are tied together, and how often James moves from hearing to doing.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The author is James, the brother of Jesus, who became the leader of the church in Jerusalem (Acts 15; Galatians 1:19). He did not believe in Jesus during the earthly ministry (John 7:5), but the risen Lord appeared to him (1 Corinthians 15:7). This may be the earliest New Testament letter, written to Jewish believers scattered by persecution. It reads like the Sermon on the Mount applied to daily life. James begins by calling himself a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ, a humble title for the Lord's own brother.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Count it all joy, my brothers, when you meet trials of various kinds" (v. 2).
2. "For you know that the testing of your faith produces steadfastness" (v. 3).
3. "If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask God, who gives generously to all without reproach, and it will be given him" (v. 5).
4. "Blessed is the man who remains steadfast under trial, for when he has stood the test he will receive the crown of life" (v. 12).
5. "But each person is tempted when he is lured and enticed by his own desire" (v. 14).
6. "Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of lights" (v. 17).

7. “But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves” (v. 22).

8. “Religion that is pure and undefiled before God the Father is this: to visit orphans and widows in their affliction, and to keep oneself unstained from the world” (v. 27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

James opens with a surprising command: “Count it all joy, my brothers, when you meet trials of various kinds.” He does not say to enjoy suffering but to consider it joy, because “the testing of your faith produces steadfastness. And let steadfastness have its full effect, that you may be perfect and complete, lacking in nothing.” Trials are the gym where faith grows strong. And when we lack wisdom to understand them, we are to ask God, who “gives generously to all without reproach.” God does not scold us for asking. But we must ask in faith, with no doubting, for the double-minded person is “like a wave of the sea that is driven and tossed by the wind.” He is unstable in all his ways.

The poor brother is told to boast in his exaltation, and the rich in his humiliation, because the rich will pass away like a flower in the grass. The verdict is given in verse 12: “Blessed is the man who remains steadfast under trial, for when he has stood the test he will receive the crown of life, which God has promised to those who love him.” The reward is life itself.

Then James separates trials from temptation. A trial tests us, and God uses it for good. But temptation is something else, and God never tempts anyone. “But each person is tempted when he is lured and enticed by his own desire. Then desire when it has conceived gives birth to sin, and sin when it is fully grown brings forth death.” James traces the path with vivid pictures: desire is the bait, sin is the offspring, and death is the end. We cannot blame God or circumstances. On the contrary, “every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of lights with whom there is no variation or shadow due to change.” The Father gives only good, and he does not change. Of his own will he brought us forth by the word of truth, that we should be a kind of firstfruits of his creatures.

The rest of the chapter is about the word. “Let every person be quick to hear, slow to speak, slow to anger; for the anger of man does not produce the righteousness of God.” We are to put away filthiness and “receive with meekness the implanted word, which is able to save your souls.” But the word must be obeyed: “Be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves.” The one who hears and does not do is like a man who looks at his face in a mirror and goes away, immediately forgetting what he was like. But the one who looks into “the perfect law, the law of liberty,” and perseveres, “being no hearer who forgets but a doer who acts, he will be blessed in his doing.” The chapter ends with three tests of real religion: a controlled tongue, care for orphans and widows, and keeping oneself unstained from the world.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 5:10-12 and Romans 5:3-5 also connect suffering to joy and hope. 1 Peter 1:6-7 speaks of faith tested by fire. 1 Kings 3:5-14 shows Solomon asking God for wisdom. Proverbs 2:1-6 says the LORD gives wisdom. Matthew 7:7-11 teaches us to ask a generous Father. Matthew 7:24-27 speaks of hearing and doing. Revelation 2:10 promises the crown of life. Deuteronomy 10:18 and Isaiah 1:17 command care for orphans and widows. Luke 8:21 says Jesus' family are those who hear and do the word.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a trial you are in now. Say out loud: God is using this to produce steadfastness. Ask him for wisdom for it, and believe he gives generously.

Look at the path in verses 14 and 15. What desire is luring you? Name it, and flee it before it grows.

Pick one thing you read in the Bible this week and do it today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for every good gift from him.
- Ask him to teach you to count trials as joy, and ask for wisdom.
- Ask him to make you a doer of the word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 120

"But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves."

JAMES 1:22

DAY 838 · WEEK 120

James 2:1-26

Partiality; faith without works is dead

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read James 2:1-26. This chapter has two parts: a warning against favoring the rich, and a famous argument that faith without works is dead. As you read, ask what kind of faith James is rejecting, and keep the whole chapter in view.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In the first-century world, wealth bought honor, and the poor were treated as nobodies. James knew congregations where a rich man in fine clothing would be given a seat of honor while a poor man was told to stand or sit on the floor. This betrayed the gospel. The second half of the chapter takes on a different danger, a faith that is claimed but never lived. The question is not whether faith or works saves, but what kind of faith is real.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “My brothers, show no partiality as you hold the faith in our Lord Jesus Christ, the Lord of glory” (v. 1).
2. “Has not God chosen those who are poor in the world to be rich in faith and heirs of the kingdom?” (v. 5).
3. “You shall love your neighbor as yourself” (v. 8).
4. “Mercy triumphs over judgment” (v. 13).
5. “What good is it, my brothers, if someone says he has faith but does not have works? Can that faith save him?” (v. 14).
6. “So also faith by itself, if it does not have works, is dead” (v. 17).
7. “Even the demons believe” (v. 19).

8 “For as the body apart from the spirit is dead, so also faith apart from works is dead” (v. 26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

James begins with a clear principle: “show no partiality as you hold the faith in our Lord Jesus Christ, the Lord of glory.” The church is where the world’s rankings are overturned. If you honor the rich man and dishonor the poor, you have “become judges with evil thoughts.” God has chosen the poor to be “rich in faith and heirs of the kingdom,” and yet they were the ones being insulted, while the rich were the ones oppressing the church and blaspheming the name. The “royal law” is to love your neighbor as yourself. To show partiality is to be “convicted by the law as transgressors,” for whoever keeps the whole law but fails in one point has become accountable for all of it. We will be judged by “the law of liberty,” so speak and act accordingly. “For judgment is without mercy to one who has shown no mercy. Mercy triumphs over judgment.”

The second half asks a pointed question: “What good is it, my brothers, if someone says he has faith but does not have works? Can that faith save him?” The Greek makes clear that the answer is no: that kind of faith cannot save. James gives an example. If a brother or sister is poorly clothed and lacking daily food, and you say, “Go in peace, be warmed and filled,” without giving what is needed, what good is that? “So also faith by itself, if it does not have works, is dead.” It is not merely weak; it is dead. Next James imagines an objector who says that one has faith and another has works. James replies, “Show me your faith apart from your works, and I will show you my faith by my works.” Then he points out that even the demons believe that God is one, and shudder. Mere agreement with a fact is not saving faith.

Two examples follow. Abraham was “justified by works when he offered up his son Isaac on the altar.” James says that “faith was active along with his works, and faith was completed by his works; and the Scripture was fulfilled that says, Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness.” Rahab the prostitute was also “justified by works when she received the messengers and sent them out by another way.” James concludes: “You see that a person is justified by works and not by faith alone. For as the body apart from the spirit is dead, so also faith apart from works is dead.”

How does this fit with Paul, who says in Romans 4 that Abraham was justified by faith apart from works? Most Reformed and evangelical interpreters answer that Paul and James are fighting different enemies. Paul argues against those who say works earn salvation. James argues against those who say that a profession without obedience is enough. Paul uses “justify” to mean being declared righteous before God, while James uses it to mean being

shown to be righteous, vindicated by what one does. Paul says we are saved by faith alone; James says the faith that saves is never alone. Both agree that real faith produces obedience. We explore this on Day 839.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 19:18 is the source of the royal law, and Jesus affirmed it in Matthew 22:39. Deuteronomy 1:17 forbids partiality in judgment. 1 Corinthians 1:26-29 says God chose the weak and low. Matthew 25:31-46 ties judgment to mercy shown to the needy. 1 John 3:17-18 echoes James on love in deed. Genesis 15:6 and Romans 4:1-5 are the texts about Abraham's faith. Genesis 22 is the offering of Isaac. Joshua 2 and Hebrews 11:31 are about Rahab. Ephesians 2:8-10 joins grace and good works.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself whom you tend to favor and whom you tend to overlook, whether at church, at work, or among your neighbors. Treat one overlooked person with real honor this week.

Meet a concrete need today, for someone near you, with more than good wishes.

Memorize verse 13 as a reminder: mercy triumphs over judgment.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have favored the wealthy or the powerful.
- Ask God to show you the faith that works through love.
- Thank him that he chose the poor to be rich in faith.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 120

"But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves."

JAMES 1:22

DAY 839 · WEEK 120

James 2:14-26; Hebrews 11:1-6

What distinguishes saving faith

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Doctrine · 19 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read James 2:14-26 and Hebrews 11:1-6. Today is a doctrinal pause on saving faith. Notice what James says dead faith lacks and what Hebrews says living faith does.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

What is saving faith? The question matters for every Christian. Paul says we are justified by faith alone, apart from works of the law. James says a person is justified by works and not by faith alone. Hebrews gives a portrait of faith in action. Taken together, the New Testament teaches that faith is the only way we receive Christ, and that the faith which receives him always leads to a changed life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “I will show you my faith by my works” (James 2:18).
2. “Even the demons believe” (James 2:19).
3. “You see that faith was active along with his works, and faith was completed by his works” (James 2:22).
4. “Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness” (James 2:23).
5. “Now faith is the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen” (Hebrews 11:1).
6. “By faith Abel offered to God a more acceptable sacrifice than Cain” (Hebrews 11:4).
7. “By faith Enoch was taken up so that he should not see death” (Hebrews 11:5).
8. “And without faith it is impossible to please him, for whoever would draw near to God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who seek him” (Hebrews 11:6).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Saving faith is the God-given trust by which a sinner rests on Christ alone for salvation. It is a gift of God (Ephesians 2:8-9) and the instrument, not the ground, by which we are justified. Our faith does not earn anything; it receives what Christ has earned.

The older theologians distinguished three elements. Knowledge (notitia): we must know the facts of the gospel, who Jesus is and what he has done. Assent (assensus): we must agree that these facts are true. Trust (fiducia): we must personally rest on Christ and entrust ourselves to him. The demons have the first two, and even tremble, but they do not have the third. Saving faith is not just believing that, but believing in: relying on a person.

Faith alone, but never alone. This phrase summarizes the Reformation teaching. We are justified by faith alone, not by faith plus works. But the faith that justifies is never by itself; it always produces works, because the Spirit who gives faith also gives new life. Works are the fruit and evidence of faith, not the root of salvation. That is why Paul can say that a person is counted righteous apart from works of the law (Romans 3:28; 4:5), and also that the only thing that counts is "faith working through love" (Galatians 5:6).

How do Paul and James fit together? Several observations help. First, they address different opponents: Paul faces legalists who rely on works of the law, and James faces people who claim faith but live in disobedience. Second, they use the word "justify" somewhat differently: for Paul, it is God's declaration that a sinner is righteous; for James, in this context, it is the vindication of a claim to faith by the evidence of works (compare Matthew 11:19). Third, they mean different things by "faith": for Paul, it is trusting in Christ; for James, the faith in view is a bare profession. Both use Abraham to make their point, and both quote Genesis 15:6.

Other traditions explain the relationship differently. The Roman Catholic Church teaches that justification includes an inward renewal and is advanced by cooperation with grace through works of love. Some Arminian traditions emphasize that faith must continue for salvation to continue. Evangelicals who hold to progressive covenantalism and Reformed convictions teach that justification is a once-for-all declaration received by faith alone, which is inseparable from sanctification. We should read James as correcting a dead orthodoxy, not as overturning Paul.

Hebrews 11 shows what living faith looks like. It is "the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen." Abel, Enoch, and Noah all acted on what God said, even when they could not see the result. "Without faith it is impossible to please him." Faith is not wishful thinking; it is confident trust in the God who speaks and promises.

STEP 4

Interpretation

James presents a test: can you show your faith? “I will show you my faith by my works.” He is not saying works replace faith. He is saying that invisible faith becomes visible by what it does. Think of a tree: you know what kind it is by its fruit. Faith in a good God leads to love for neighbor, in the way that trust in a doctor leads to following his prescription.

His example is Abraham, who offered Isaac. Abraham had been counted righteous in Genesis 15, many years earlier, when he simply believed God. In Genesis 22, his obedience demonstrated that his faith was real. “Faith was active along with his works, and faith was completed by his works.” Completed here means brought to its intended end, its full expression, not that something was lacking in the faith. The “fulfilled” Scripture is Genesis 15:6: what God declared about Abraham was shown to be true.

Hebrews 11 gives the same picture from another angle. Faith believes that God exists and that he rewards those who seek him. Abel offered a better sacrifice because he trusted God; Enoch walked with God and was taken; Noah built an ark. Each acted on a word from God. In every case, faith moves people to act. So the question for us is not only “Do I believe?” but “Whom do I trust, and what does my life show?”

The comfort here is that faith is not a work we produce to earn God’s favor. A small faith in a great Savior saves. The Lord can work with a mustard seed. But the faith that saves does not stay inactive.

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 2:8-10 joins grace, faith, and works. Romans 3:28, 4:1-5, and Galatians 2:16 give Paul’s statements on justification by faith. Galatians 5:6 speaks of faith working through love. Genesis 15:6 and 22:1-19 are the two scenes from Abraham’s life. Matthew 7:16-20 says we know a tree by its fruit. Matthew 17:20 says faith like a mustard seed is enough. John 6:28-29 says the work of God is to believe in the one he sent. Titus 2:11-14 and 3:8 tie grace to good works. Mark 9:24 is the prayer, “I believe; help my unbelief!”

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself the three questions: Do I know the gospel? Do I agree it is true? Have I put my whole trust in Christ to save me?

If you doubt your faith, look not for a perfect record but for a direction: are you growing in love for God and neighbor?

Choose one act of obedience that expresses your trust in God today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the gift of faith.
- Tell him that you trust in Christ alone, not in your works.
- Ask him to let that faith show in what you do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 120

"But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves."

JAMES 1:22

DAY 840 · WEEK 120

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read James 1:22 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves."

JAMES 1:22

REST

Meditation

This verse is simple and uncomfortable. It is possible to hear the word every week, to read the Bible daily, to take notes at a sermon, and still be deceived about ourselves. The danger James describes is not ignorance but self-deception: thinking that because we have heard, we have obeyed.

Doing the word does not mean earning salvation. It means that the word we receive changes the way we live. The man who looks in the mirror and walks away forgetting what he saw has missed the point of the mirror. Scripture shows us who we are and who we are becoming in Christ, and then it calls us to act.

Ask the Spirit today: what have I heard that I have not yet done? Then take the first small step.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the General Epistles with James. In chapter 1, trials were called joy because they produce steadfastness, we were told to ask God for wisdom, we saw how desire gives birth to sin, and we were charged to be doers of the word and not hearers only. In chapter 2, James called the church to show no partiality, to love the neighbor as the royal law requires, and to prove faith by works. On Day 839 we paused to consider saving faith: knowing, agreeing, and trusting, faith alone but never alone, and how Paul and James fit together alongside the portrait of faith in Hebrews 11.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

James says to count trials as joy because they produce steadfastness. What trial are you in or near right now, and how might God be using it to grow your faith?

James calls us to be doers of the word. What is one thing you have heard from Scripture or a sermon recently that you have not yet put into practice? What is a first step?

Our works do not earn our salvation, because Christ has already done everything needed. How does it change your obedience to know that you are already accepted because of him?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for rest and for his word.

Ask him to make you a doer and not only a hearer.

Ask him to keep you from deceiving yourself.

DAY 841 · WEEK 121

James 3:1-4:17

The tongue; worldliness; humility before God

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 35 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read James 3:1-4:17. Two themes run through these chapters: the power of the tongue and the war between friendship with the world and humility before God. Notice the contrast between wisdom from below and wisdom from above.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

James is writing to churches where speech was causing division. Teachers were quick to claim authority, and quarrels were breaking out among believers. James traces conflict to its source in the heart and calls the church to humble repentance. In Jewish wisdom writing, the tongue and the heart were closely tied, and James follows this tradition, with echoes of Proverbs and the teaching of Jesus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “How great a forest is set ablaze by such a small fire!” (3:5).
2. “No human being can tame the tongue” (3:8).
3. “But the wisdom from above is first pure, then peaceable, gentle, open to reason, full of mercy and good fruits, impartial and sincere” (3:17).
4. “What causes quarrels and what causes fights among you?” (4:1).
5. “God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble” (4:6).
6. “Draw near to God, and he will draw near to you” (4:8).
7. “For you are a mist that appears for a little time and then vanishes” (4:14).
8. “So whoever knows the right thing to do and fails to do it, for him it is sin” (4:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

James begins with a warning for teachers: “Not many of you should become teachers, my brothers, for you know that we who teach will be judged with greater strictness. For we all stumble in many ways.” Anyone who does not stumble in what he says is a perfect man. Then come the pictures: a bit in a horse’s mouth, a rudder on a ship, a spark in a forest. The tongue is small but steers the whole body. “So also the tongue is a small member, yet it boasts of great things. How great a forest is set ablaze by such a small fire!” It is “a world of unrighteousness” and “set on fire by hell.” Every kind of creature has been tamed by mankind, “but no human being can tame the tongue. It is a restless evil, full of deadly poison.” Our greatest inconsistency is that “with it we bless our Lord and Father, and with it we curse people who are made in the likeness of God.” A spring does not pour out fresh and salt water. Only the Spirit can change the heart so that the mouth follows.

James then contrasts two kinds of wisdom. Bitter jealousy and selfish ambition are “earthly, unspiritual, demonic,” and where they are found, there is disorder and every vile practice. “But the wisdom from above is first pure, then peaceable, gentle, open to reason, full of mercy and good fruits, impartial and sincere. And a harvest of righteousness is sown in peace by those who make peace.” This is a checklist for every conflict.

In chapter 4, James asks where conflict comes from: “What causes quarrels and what causes fights among you? Is it not this, that your passions are at war within you?” We desire and do not have, so we murder (in heart); we covet and cannot obtain, so we fight. We do not have because we do not ask, or we ask wrongly, to spend it on our passions. He calls his readers “adulterous people,” echoing the prophets’ language of God’s people unfaithful to their covenant husband: “Whoever wishes to be a friend of the world makes himself an enemy of God.” But God gives more grace: “God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble.”

The remedy is a series of commands: “Submit yourselves therefore to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you. Draw near to God, and he will draw near to you. Cleanse your hands, you sinners, and purify your hearts, you double-minded.” Grieve over sin, and “humble yourselves before the Lord, and he will exalt you.” Do not speak evil of one another, since it makes you a judge of the law instead of a doer. The chapter closes with a warning to the self-assured planner: “You do not know what tomorrow will bring. What is your life? For you are a mist that appears for a little time and then vanishes.” Instead, say, “If the Lord wills, we will live and do this or that.” And one summary sin: “Whoever knows the right thing to do and fails to do it, for him it is sin.” Sins of omission count.

STEP 5

Connection

Proverbs 18:21 says death and life are in the power of the tongue. Matthew 12:34-37 teaches that the mouth speaks from the heart's abundance. Ephesians 4:29 and Colossians 4:6 direct our speech. Genesis 1:26-27 is behind the "likeness of God." Hosea 2 and Jeremiah 3 use adultery as an image of unfaithfulness. Proverbs 3:34 is quoted in 4:6, and 1 Peter 5:5-9 echoes it. Matthew 5:9 blesses peacemakers. Proverbs 27:1 and Luke 12:16-21 warn about boasting about tomorrow. Psalm 39:5 and 90:5-6 describe life as a breath.

STEP 6

Application

Before you speak in a hard conversation today, run it through verse 3:17: is it pure, peaceable, gentle, open to reason, and merciful?

Name a quarrel and ask what desire is behind it (4:1-2). Confess it to God, and make the first move toward peace.

Practice saying "If the Lord wills" as you plan the week, and mean it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what your tongue has done.
- Ask him to change your heart because you cannot tame your tongue.
- Ask him to give you wisdom from above.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 121

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."

1 PETER 1:3-4

DAY 842 · WEEK 121

James 5:1-20

The rich; patience; prayer; restoring the wanderer

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read James 5:1-20. James closes with a warning to the rich, a call to patience, and instruction on prayer and care for one another. Notice how often James points to the coming of the Lord.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Many of the first Christians were poor, and landowners sometimes withheld wages from day laborers. James speaks like an Old Testament prophet against such injustice. He then turns to the suffering believers and calls them to wait for the Lord's return with patience, like a farmer waiting for rain. The letter ends with a practical section on prayer, anointing the sick, and restoring those who wander.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Come now, you rich, weep and howl for the miseries that are coming upon you" (v. 1).
2. "Be patient, therefore, brothers, until the coming of the Lord" (v. 7).
3. "Behold, we consider those blessed who remained steadfast" (v. 11).
4. "Is anyone among you suffering? Let him pray" (v. 13).
5. "Let him call for the elders of the church, and let them pray over him, anointing him with oil in the name of the Lord" (v. 14).
6. "The prayer of a righteous person has great power as it is working" (v. 16).
7. "Elijah was a man with a nature like ours, and he prayed fervently that it might not rain" (v. 17).

8 “Whoever brings back a sinner from his wandering will save his soul from death and will cover a multitude of sins” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

James speaks to the wealthy who trust in riches: “Come now, you rich, weep and howl for the miseries that are coming upon you. Your riches have rotted and your garments are moth-eaten. Your gold and silver have corroded, and their corrosion will be evidence against you.” Their sin is hoarding in the last days, and especially withholding the wages of the laborers who mowed their fields. Those cries have “reached the ears of the Lord of hosts.” They have lived in luxury and self-indulgence, fattening their hearts “in a day of slaughter,” and have condemned and murdered the righteous person, who does not resist. James is not condemning wealth in itself but its misuse and the injustice by which it was gained.

Then he turns to the suffering: “Be patient, therefore, brothers, until the coming of the Lord.” The farmer waits for the precious fruit of the earth, being patient until it receives the early and the late rains. “You also, be patient. Establish your hearts, for the coming of the Lord is at hand.” Do not grumble against one another. The Judge is standing at the door. For examples, he points to the prophets and to Job: “You have heard of the steadfastness of Job, and you have seen the purpose of the Lord, how the Lord is compassionate and merciful.” Our suffering has a purpose, and the Lord’s character is compassion. He also warns against oaths: “Let your yes be yes and your no be no.” Be people whose word is reliable.

The final section is about prayer. “Is anyone among you suffering? Let him pray. Is anyone cheerful? Let him sing praise.” The church should pray in every circumstance. “Is anyone among you sick? Let him call for the elders of the church, and let them pray over him, anointing him with oil in the name of the Lord. And the prayer of faith will save the one who is sick, and the Lord will raise him up. And if he has committed sins, he will be forgiven.” Christians differ on the meaning of the anointing: some take it as medicinal (oil was used as medicine), some as symbolic of setting apart for God, and some as a sacramental act. In every reading, the healing comes from the Lord, not the oil, and the emphasis is on prayer by the elders. Not every sick person is healed in this life, as Paul’s thorn and Timothy’s ailments show, but the Lord hears and may raise up.

“Therefore, confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous person has great power as it is working.” Elijah is the example. He “was a man with a nature like ours,” yet when he prayed, the rain stopped for three and a half years, and when he prayed again, the heavens gave rain. We are as weak as Elijah, but we pray to the same God. The letter ends without a benediction, with a charge: if anyone wanders from the truth and someone brings him back, “let him know that whoever

brings back a sinner from his wandering will save his soul from death and will cover a multitude of sins." Caring for a wandering brother is among the most loving things a Christian can do.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 24:14-15 and Leviticus 19:13 forbid withholding wages. Isaiah 5:8-10 and Amos 5:11-12 are prophetic warnings against the rich. Matthew 6:19-21 and Luke 12:16-21 speak of treasure. Deuteronomy 11:14 mentions early and late rains. Job 42:10-17 shows the end of Job's story. Matthew 5:33-37 is Jesus' teaching on oaths. Mark 6:13 mentions anointing the sick. 1 Kings 17-18 is the Elijah account. Galatians 6:1 and Matthew 18:15 speak of restoring a brother. Proverbs 10:12 and 1 Peter 4:8 say love covers a multitude of sins.

STEP 6

Application

Be honest about how you use money. Ask whether you are being generous or hoarding, and whether you pay what you owe.

Pray for someone who is sick, and ask your pastor how your church cares for the sick.

Think of someone who has wandered from the faith. Pray for them, and reach out this week with love.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from trusting in riches or using them unjustly.
- Ask him to give you patience.
- Pray for someone who has wandered, and ask what you might do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 121

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."

1 PETER 1:3-4

DAY 843 · WEEK 121

Psalm 12

Save, O LORD, the tongue and its lying words

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 12. It is a short prayer of David about a world full of lies. Notice the contrast between the words of the wicked and the words of the LORD.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 12 is a psalm of David, "according to The Sheminith," possibly a musical direction. David prays in a time when truth seems to have vanished, when flattery and boasting fill the land and the poor are trampled. It fits our reading in James, where the tongue can be a fire or a source of blessing, and teaches what to do when the words around us cannot be trusted.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Save, O LORD, for the godly one is gone; for the faithful have vanished from among the children of man" (v. 1).
2. "Everyone utters lies to his neighbor; with flattering lips and a double heart they speak" (v. 2).
3. "May the LORD cut off all flattering lips" (v. 3).
4. "With our tongue we will prevail" (v. 4).
5. "Because the poor are plundered, because the needy groan, I will now arise" (v. 5).
6. "The words of the LORD are pure words, like silver refined in a furnace on the ground, purified seven times" (v. 6).
7. "You, O LORD, will keep them; you will guard us from this generation forever" (v. 7).
8. "On every side the wicked prowl, as vileness is exalted among the children of man" (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a cry of alarm: “Save, O LORD, for the godly one is gone; for the faithful have vanished from among the children of man!” David feels that no honest person remains. The problem is speech: “Everyone utters lies to his neighbor; with flattering lips and a double heart they speak.” The phrase “a double heart” is literally “a heart and a heart”: saying one thing and meaning another. This is the same double-mindedness James warns about. David asks God to cut off flattering lips and the boastful tongue, those who say, “With our tongue we will prevail, our lips are with us; who is master over us?” They believe their words are their own and answer to no one.

Then the LORD speaks, and the psalm turns: “Because the poor are plundered, because the needy groan, I will now arise,” says the LORD; “I will place him in the safety for which he longs.” God hears the groaning of the needy and responds with a promise. Where human words are lies, his words can be trusted: “The words of the LORD are pure words, like silver refined in a furnace on the ground, purified seven times.” Silver purified seven times has no impurity. We can rest our whole weight on what God says.

The psalm ends with confidence mixed with realism. “You, O LORD, will keep them; you will guard us from this generation forever.” The promise is of protection, not of an easy time: “On every side the wicked prowl, as vileness is exalted among the children of man.” The wicked still prowl, and shame is honored. But the word of the LORD stands. This is the experience of the church in every age. Evil seems to be flourishing, yet God’s words are pure, and God keeps his own. In Christ, the Word who is the truth (John 14:6), we find the final answer. The one who “committed no sin, neither was deceit found in his mouth” (1 Peter 2:22) is the faithful one in a world of liars.

STEP 5

Connection

James 3:1-12 speaks of the tongue. Psalm 5:9 and 55:21 describe flattering and deceitful speech. Psalm 119:140 and Proverbs 30:5 describe the purity of God’s word. Isaiah 3:14-15 speaks of the plundered poor. Exodus 3:7-8 shows God hearing the groaning of the oppressed. Isaiah 33:10 has a similar “now I will arise.” John 14:6 and 17:17 present Jesus and the word as truth. 1 Peter 2:22 speaks of Christ’s speech. Ephesians 4:25 commands truth-telling. Revelation 21:8 and 22:15 speak of the end of liars.

STEP 6

Application

Make yourself a person of single-hearted speech today: say what you mean, and refuse flattery.

When you feel that truth has vanished around you, turn to Scripture as pure silver and read a passage slowly.

Pray for the poor and needy in your community, and ask what the LORD may want you to do.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what lies and flattery you see.

Thank him that his words are pure.

Ask him to keep you from boasting and double speech.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 121

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."

1 PETER 1:3-4

DAY 844 · WEEK 121

Psalm 15

Who shall sojourn on your holy hill?

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 15. This short psalm asks who may dwell with God and gives the answer in a list of ten character marks. Read it slowly, and notice that the list is about everyday integrity.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 15 is a psalm of David, probably used as an entrance liturgy when worshipers approached the sanctuary. A question is asked: who may be a guest in God's tent? The answer is a description of a person whose life matches their worship. James would call this a doer of the word. The psalm raises a question that only the gospel can answer: who is so blameless?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, who shall sojourn in your tent? Who shall dwell on your holy hill?" (v. 1).
2. "He who walks blamelessly and does what is right" (v. 2).
3. "And speaks truth in his heart" (v. 2).
4. "Who does not slander with his tongue and does no evil to his friend" (v. 3).
5. "In whose eyes a vile person is despised, but who honors those who fear the LORD" (v. 4).
6. "Who swears to his own hurt and does not change" (v. 4).
7. "Who does not put out his money at interest" (v. 5).
8. "He who does these things shall never be moved" (v. 5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a question about access: “O LORD, who shall sojourn in your tent? Who shall dwell on your holy hill?” To sojourn means to stay as a guest, and the tent is the sanctuary where God meets his people. The question is not about earning a place but about the kind of person who belongs there. In the Old Testament, to be close to God’s holy presence is a great privilege and requires holiness.

The answer has three layers. First, general character: “He who walks blamelessly and does what is right and speaks truth in his heart.” Blamelessness means integrity, a life that is whole. Truth is spoken not only with the lips but in the heart; no gap exists between inner conviction and outer speech. Second, how he treats his neighbor: he “does not slander with his tongue and does no evil to his friend, nor takes up a reproach against his friend.” Gossip and slander are named along with outright harm. Third, how he deals with the world: he despises a vile person (does not admire the corrupt) and honors those who fear the LORD. He keeps his promise even when it costs him: “who swears to his own hurt and does not change.” His word is his bond. He does not exploit the needy by charging them interest (Exodus 22:25) and does not take bribes against the innocent.

“He who does these things shall never be moved.” This is the life the whole of Scripture calls for. But who can say that he fits this description? None of us. Here we see our need for Christ. He is the one who walked blamelessly, who spoke truth from the heart, who kept his word even to his own hurt, going to the cross. He alone ascended the hill of the LORD with clean hands. Those who are in him are welcomed into God’s presence, not because they match this psalm but because he does, and his righteousness is counted as theirs. And then, by the Spirit, he begins to form this character in us. The list in Psalm 15 is both a mirror and a goal.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 24:3-6 asks a similar question. Isaiah 33:14-16 and Micah 6:6-8 also describe who may dwell with God. Exodus 22:25 and Deuteronomy 23:19-20 forbid interest on loans to the poor. Exodus 23:8 forbids bribes. Matthew 5:33-37 teaches on oaths. Ephesians 4:25-32 tells believers to put away falsehood and slander. 1 Peter 2:22 says no deceit was found in Christ’s mouth. Hebrews 4:14-16 invites us to draw near through our high priest. 2 Corinthians 5:21 says we become the righteousness of God in him. James 1:26-27 and 3:1-12 also test religion by speech and conduct.

STEP 6

Application

Read the ten marks slowly and mark the two where you most need growth. Ask the Spirit for help.

Ask whether you have broken a promise that cost you. If you can still keep it, do so.

Thank Christ that you are welcomed into God's tent because of his righteousness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask who may dwell on God's hill, and tell him you cannot by your own righteousness.

Thank Jesus for walking blamelessly and speaking truth.

Ask him to make you truthful and faithful.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 121

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."

1 PETER 1:3-4

DAY 845 · WEEK 121

Psalm 24

Pure heart, clean hands

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 24. This psalm moves from the creation to the clean-handed worshiper to the King of glory entering the gates. Read the second half as a call and response, with different voices asking and answering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 24 is a psalm of David, likely sung when the ark of the covenant was brought up to Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6). It is a processional psalm with three parts: the LORD's ownership of the earth (vv. 1-2), the character of those who may approach him (vv. 3-6), and the entry of the King (vv. 7-10). It pairs naturally with Psalm 15 and with James's call to purity of heart. Christians have long read it as a picture of Christ's ascension.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The earth is the LORD's and the fullness thereof, the world and those who dwell therein" (v. 1).
2. "Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place?" (v. 3).
3. "He who has clean hands and a pure heart" (v. 4).
4. "He will receive blessing from the LORD and righteousness from the God of his salvation" (v. 5).
5. "Lift up your heads, O gates! And be lifted up, O ancient doors, that the King of glory may come in" (v. 7).
6. "Who is this King of glory? The LORD, strong and mighty, the LORD, mighty in battle!" (v. 8).

7. “Who is this King of glory? The LORD of hosts, he is the King of glory!” (v. 10).

8. “For he has founded it upon the seas and established it upon the rivers” (v. 2).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts with the biggest claim possible: “The earth is the LORD’s and the fullness thereof, the world and those who dwell therein, for he has founded it upon the seas and established it upon the rivers.” Everything belongs to God, including us. Nothing in the world is outside his claim. So the question is: how can anyone come to the One who owns all things?

“Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart, who does not lift up his soul to what is false and does not swear deceitfully.” Clean hands refer to actions, and a pure heart refers to motives. This is the same standard as Psalm 15, and James echoes it when he calls for cleansing hands and purifying hearts (James 4:8). Such a person “will receive blessing from the LORD and righteousness from the God of his salvation.” Even this righteousness is a gift from the God of his salvation. Such is “the generation of those who seek him, who seek the face of the God of Jacob.”

Then the procession arrives at the gates. A voice cries: “Lift up your heads, O gates! And be lifted up, O ancient doors, that the King of glory may come in!” A watchman replies: “Who is this King of glory?” And the answer comes: “The LORD, strong and mighty, the LORD, mighty in battle!” The call is repeated, and the answer enlarges: “The LORD of hosts, he is the King of glory!” The psalm leaves us at the threshold with the King entering.

Christians have long seen in this the ascension of Christ. The only one with truly clean hands and a pure heart is Jesus. He ascended the hill, was received into the Father’s presence, and entered the gates in victory after conquering sin and death. And because he has entered as our forerunner, we can follow him. The King of glory is also the one who welcomes the humble to his side. The gates open for him, and through him they open for us.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 15 is the companion psalm. 1 Corinthians 10:26 quotes verse 1. 2 Samuel 6:12-15 describes the ark entering Jerusalem. Isaiah 6:1-5 shows a holy King and an unclean people. Matthew 5:8 blesses the pure in heart. James 4:8 calls for cleansing of hands and hearts. Ephesians 4:8-10 and Acts 1:9-11 describe the ascension. Hebrews 4:14, 6:19-20, and 9:24 speak of Christ entering heaven as forerunner. 1 Corinthians 15:57 gives thanks for victory. Revelation 5:11-13 shows the worship of the King.

STEP 6

Application

Say verse 1 over your day: the earth is the LORD's and everything in it, including my money, time, and work.

Ask the Lord to give you clean hands and a pure heart, and confess anything he shows you.

Open the gates of your heart to the King of glory, and welcome him in as Lord over one area where you have held back.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you cannot ascend by your own clean hands.

Thank Jesus who ascended for you.

Open the gates of your life to the King of glory.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 121

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."

1 PETER 1:3-4

DAY 846 · WEEK 121

1 Peter 1:1-2:12

Living hope; the church as new Israel; holy living

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 37 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Peter 1:1-2:12. Peter writes to scattered Christians who suffer for their faith. Notice how he moves from the great things God has done (a living hope, a precious inheritance) to a call to holiness, and then to a new identity as God's people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The apostle Peter wrote this letter around AD 62 to 64, probably from Rome (called "Babylon" in 5:13), to believers in the northern provinces of Asia Minor. Most were Gentiles, though Peter speaks to them in language drawn from Israel. They were "elect exiles," strangers in a hostile culture, and they faced slander and growing persecution. Peter, who once denied his Lord, writes with the gentleness of a restored man to encourage them to hope.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead" (1:3).
2. "The tested genuineness of your faith" (1:7).
3. "You also be holy in all your conduct" (1:15).
4. "With the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot" (1:19).
5. "Since you have been born again, not of perishable seed but of imperishable, through the living and abiding word of God" (1:23).
6. "You yourselves like living stones are being built up as a spiritual house, to be a holy priesthood" (2:5).

7. “But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession” (2:9).

8. “Keep your conduct among the Gentiles honorable, so that when they speak against you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day of visitation” (2:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter greets his readers as “elect exiles of the Dispersion,” chosen according to the foreknowledge of God the Father, in the sanctification of the Spirit, for obedience to Jesus Christ and for sprinkling with his blood. The Trinity is present from the first verse. Then he bursts into praise: “Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you, who by God’s power are being guarded through faith for a salvation ready to be revealed in the last time.” Our hope is alive because Christ is alive, our inheritance is kept safe, and we are kept safe for it.

In this they rejoice, though they now suffer various trials, “so that the tested genuineness of your faith, more precious than gold that perishes though it is tested by fire, may be found to result in praise and glory and honor at the revelation of Jesus Christ.” Though they have not seen Christ, they love him, and they rejoice with joy that is inexpressible and filled with glory. The prophets searched and inquired about this salvation; angels long to look into these things.

From this foundation, Peter calls for holiness. “Therefore, preparing your minds for action, and being sober-minded, set your hope fully on the grace that will be brought to you at the revelation of Jesus Christ.” Do not conform to the passions of your former ignorance, “but as he who called you is holy, you also be holy in all your conduct, since it is written, You shall be holy, for I am holy.” They were ransomed “not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot.” He was foreknown before the foundation of the world but made manifest in the last times for their sake. The new birth is by “the living and abiding word of God.” Love one another earnestly from a pure heart. “The grass withers, and the flower falls, but the word of the Lord remains forever.” That word is the good news that was preached.

Chapter 2 begins with putting away malice, deceit, hypocrisy, envy, and slander, and craving “pure spiritual milk, that by it you may grow up into salvation.” Christ is the living stone, rejected by men but chosen and precious in God’s sight. Believers, too, are “living stones”

being built up as a spiritual house, “to be a holy priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ.” Peter applies Old Testament texts about the stone: to those who believe, he is precious; to those who do not, he is a stone of stumbling.

Then the great statement of identity: “But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession, that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light. Once you were not a people, but now you are God’s people; once you had not received mercy, but now you have received mercy.” These phrases were used of Israel at Sinai (Exodus 19:5-6) and now belong to the church, made up of Jew and Gentile. This fits the progressive covenantal view that the church is the new covenant people of God, not a replacement but the fulfillment of Israel’s calling in Christ. The purpose is mission: to proclaim his excellencies. As “sojourners and exiles,” they are to abstain from the passions of the flesh and keep their conduct honorable, so that their good deeds may lead even their accusers to glorify God.

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 1:3-14 is a similar burst of praise. John 3:3-8 and Titus 3:5 speak of new birth. Isaiah 40:6-8 is quoted in 1:24-25. Leviticus 11:44-45 and 19:2 are the source for “be holy.” Isaiah 53 stands behind the lamb. Exodus 19:5-6 is the origin of “kingdom of priests, a holy nation.” Hosea 1:6-10 and 2:23 are behind 2:10. Psalm 118:22 and Isaiah 28:16 are the stone texts. Revelation 1:6 and 5:10 speak of a kingdom and priests. Matthew 5:16 also speaks of good works that glorify the Father. Hebrews 11:13 calls believers strangers and exiles.

STEP 6

Application

Praise God for your living hope before you do anything else today. Read 1:3-5 aloud.

Think about the phrase “chosen race, royal priesthood, holy nation, people for his own possession.” How does it change how you see yourself?

Choose one way to live honorably before a neighbor or coworker who is critical of your faith.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bless God for causing you to be born again to a living hope.

Thank him for keeping an inheritance for you.

Ask him to help you live as a stranger and exile who is holy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 121

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."

1 PETER 1:3-4

DAY 847 · WEEK 121

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Peter 1:3-4 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."

1 PETER 1:3-4

REST

Meditation

Peter begins with praise, not with instruction. Before he tells his readers what to do, he reminds them what God has done. Everything flows from mercy: "According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again." We did not earn it, and we did not start it.

The hope is "living" because it is tied to the resurrection of Jesus Christ. A dead Savior would give a dead hope. Because he lives, our hope is not wishful thinking but a confident expectation.

The inheritance has three descriptions: imperishable (it cannot decay), undefiled (it cannot be corrupted), unfading (it cannot lose its beauty). And it is kept in heaven for you. Nothing here is stored where thieves or time can reach it.

When your week was hard, which phrase did you need most? Say it back to God as a prayer of thanks.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read James 3 to 5 and the opening of 1 Peter. James showed us the tongue that no human can tame, the two kinds of wisdom, the source of quarrels in our desires, humility before God, the brevity of life, the warning to the rich, patience until the Lord comes, and prayer for the sick and for the wanderer. Three psalms offered further wisdom: Psalm 12 on lying lips and the pure words of the LORD, Psalm 15 on who may dwell in God's tent, and Psalm 24 on the clean hands that ascend the hill and the King of glory who enters the gates. In 1 Peter 1:1 to 2:12, we heard of a living hope, tested faith, a call to holiness, redemption by the precious blood of Christ, and our identity as a chosen race, royal priesthood, holy nation, and people for God's own possession.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

James says no human being can tame the tongue. Where has your speech been most difficult to control, and how can you ask God to change your heart so that your words follow?

Psalms 15 and 24 describe someone with clean hands and a pure heart. Since none of us fits this description, how does Christ's perfect righteousness change the way you approach God?

Peter calls believers "a people for his own possession" who were "once not a people." How does belonging to God's people shape the way you live as an exile in this world?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for rest and for the living hope in Jesus.

Ask him to guard your faith.

Rest in his keeping.

DAY 848 · WEEK 122

1 Peter 2:13-3:22

Submission; suffering for righteousness; Christ's example

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Peter 2:13-3:22. Peter applies the gospel to life under authority: citizens, servants, wives, husbands, and the whole church. Notice that Christ is the pattern in every relationship and that suffering for doing good is a calling.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Christians in Asia Minor were slandered as lawless, antisocial, and subversive. Peter does not tell them to withdraw from society. He tells them to live so well that the accusations fall flat. The "household codes" in this section (similar to those in Ephesians 5-6 and Colossians 3) were not new in the ancient world, but Peter grounds them in Christ's example. Many of the servants and wives he addresses were in difficult situations, and he points them to the Suffering Servant.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Be subject for the Lord's sake to every human institution" (2:13).
2. "Honor everyone. Love the brotherhood. Fear God. Honor the emperor" (2:17).
3. "For to this you have been called, because Christ also suffered for you, leaving you an example, so that you might follow in his steps" (2:21).
4. "He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness" (2:24).
5. "Do not repay evil for evil or reviling for reviling, but on the contrary, bless" (3:9).
6. "But in your hearts honor Christ the Lord as holy, always being prepared to make a defense to anyone who asks you for a reason for the hope that is in you" (3:15).

7. “For it is better to suffer for doing good, if that should be God’s will, than for doing evil” (3:17).

8. “Christ also suffered once for sins, the righteous for the unrighteous, that he might bring us to God” (3:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter first addresses believers as citizens: “Be subject for the Lord’s sake to every human institution, whether it be to the emperor as supreme, or to governors.” Government exists to punish wrongdoing and praise those who do good. “Live as people who are free, not using your freedom as a cover-up for evil, but living as servants of God.” Then four short commands: “Honor everyone. Love the brotherhood. Fear God. Honor the emperor.” Honor goes to all, but fear belongs to God alone. This does not mean unlimited submission; when the state demands what God forbids, we must obey God (Acts 5:29).

Next he speaks to household servants: be subject to your masters with all respect, even to the unjust. Why? “For to this you have been called, because Christ also suffered for you, leaving you an example, so that you might follow in his steps.” Then Peter describes the Suffering Servant in the words of Isaiah 53. “He committed no sin, neither was deceit found in his mouth. When he was reviled, he did not revile in return; when he suffered, he did not threaten, but continued entrusting himself to him who judges justly. He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. By his wounds you have been healed. For you were straying like sheep, but have now returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls.” The cross is both an example and an atonement: first Christ is our substitute, and only then our model. We cannot imitate what we have not received.

Chapter 3 turns to marriage. Wives are to be subject to their own husbands, so that even if some do not obey the word, “they may be won without a word by the conduct of their wives.” Their beauty is to be that of “the hidden person of the heart with the imperishable beauty of a gentle and quiet spirit, which in God’s sight is very precious.” Husbands are to live with their wives “in an understanding way, showing honor to the woman as the weaker vessel, since they are heirs with you of the grace of life, so that your prayers may not be hindered.” Husbands and wives are equal heirs. Christians differ on how to apply the language of submission: complementarians see a distinct role of loving headship and willing submission rooted in creation, while egalitarians stress mutual submission and see the instruction as addressing a cultural setting. All agree that Peter calls both to humble, honoring love, and that abuse is never permissible.

Then the whole church: “have unity of mind, sympathy, brotherly love, a tender heart, and a humble mind.” Return blessing for insult. Do not fear what they fear, “but in your hearts honor Christ the Lord as holy, always being prepared to make a defense to anyone who asks you for a reason for the hope that is in you; yet do it with gentleness and respect.” Notice that the world asks about our hope when it sees us respond well to suffering. Keep a good conscience, “for it is better to suffer for doing good, if that should be God’s will, than for doing evil.”

The ground of it is Christ: “For Christ also suffered once for sins, the righteous for the unrighteous, that he might bring us to God, being put to death in the flesh but made alive in the spirit.” The next verses (3:19-22) are among the hardest in the New Testament. Who are the “spirits in prison” to whom Christ proclaimed? Some think the fallen angels of Genesis 6 (as in 1 Enoch), to whom the risen Christ announced his victory; some think the people of Noah’s day, to whom Christ preached through Noah by his Spirit; and some think Christ descended to the dead. Likewise, “Baptism, which corresponds to this, now saves you” has been taken in different ways: as the outward sign that points to the inward reality, as an appeal to God for a good conscience, or as a means of grace. All agree that it is Christ’s resurrection that saves, and that he is now at God’s right hand, with angels, authorities, and powers subject to him.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 13:1-7 speaks of governing authorities, and Acts 4:19 and 5:29 show the limit. Isaiah 53:4-12 is behind 2:22-25. Ephesians 5:22-33 and Colossians 3:18-4:1 are the parallel household codes. Genesis 6:1-4 and Jude 6 touch on the spirits in prison. Genesis 6-8 is the account of Noah. 1 Peter 4:6 mentions the gospel preached to the dead. Romans 6:3-4 and Colossians 2:11-12 speak of baptism. Matthew 5:38-48 teaches blessing enemies. Psalm 34:12-16 is quoted in 3:10-12. Hebrews 1:3 and Ephesians 1:20-22 say Christ is at the right hand.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a person in authority over you whom you find hard to respect. Ask how you can honor them as unto the Lord, and how you can pray for them.

Rehearse 3:15 so you are ready to explain your hope to someone who asks. Write out a two-minute answer.

If you are married, ask your spouse how you can show them honor this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for not reviling in return when he was reviled.

Thank him for bearing your sins.

Ask him to help you suffer well when you suffer for doing right.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 122

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

2 PETER 3:18

DAY 849 · WEEK 122

1 Peter 4:1-5:14

Suffering; elders; the roaring lion; grace is sufficient

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 45 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Peter 4:1-5:14. Peter concludes by speaking of how to live in the face of suffering, how to use your gifts, how elders should lead, and how to resist the devil. Notice the repeated mention of grace and glory.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Persecution against Christians was growing. Peter reminds his readers not to be surprised, since suffering is the normal path for those who follow the crucified Lord. He then gives instruction for the community: serve one another, elders shepherd the flock, the young submit, and all clothe themselves with humility. Peter, who was called to feed Christ's sheep (John 21:15-17), writes now as a fellow elder.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Above all, keep loving one another earnestly, since love covers a multitude of sins" (4:8).
2. "As each has received a gift, use it to serve one another, as good stewards of God's varied grace" (4:10).
3. "Beloved, do not be surprised at the fiery trial when it comes upon you to test you, as though something strange were happening to you" (4:12).
4. "But rejoice insofar as you share Christ's sufferings, that you may also rejoice and be glad when his glory is revealed" (4:13).
5. "Shepherd the flock of God that is among you, exercising oversight, not under compulsion, but willingly, as God would have you" (5:2).

6. “Casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you” (5:7).

7. “Be sober-minded; be watchful. Your adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour” (5:8).

8. “And after you have suffered a little while, the God of all grace, who has called you to his eternal glory in Christ, will himself restore, confirm, strengthen, and establish you” (5:10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter begins with a call to arm ourselves with the same way of thinking as Christ. “Since therefore Christ suffered in the flesh, arm yourselves with the same way of thinking, for whoever has suffered in the flesh has ceased from sin.” Suffering weans us from the old life. The time is past for doing what the Gentiles want, in sensuality and drunkenness; their surprise that you do not join them leads them to malign you. But they will give account to him who is ready to judge the living and the dead. “The end of all things is at hand; therefore be self-controlled and sober-minded for the sake of your prayers.”

Then the life of the church. “Above all, keep loving one another earnestly, since love covers a multitude of sins.” Show hospitality without grumbling. Every believer has a gift: “As each has received a gift, use it to serve one another, as good stewards of God’s varied grace: whoever speaks, as one who speaks oracles of God; whoever serves, as one who serves by the strength that God supplies, in order that in everything God may be glorified through Jesus Christ.” The gifts are for serving, and the aim is God’s glory.

Next, how to think about suffering: “Beloved, do not be surprised at the fiery trial when it comes upon you to test you, as though something strange were happening to you. But rejoice insofar as you share Christ’s sufferings, that you may also rejoice and be glad when his glory is revealed.” Suffering is not a sign that God has abandoned you; it is a share in Christ’s. “Blessed are you” if you are insulted for the name of Christ, for the Spirit of glory rests upon you. Only make sure you suffer for being a Christian and not for being a wrongdoer. “Yet if anyone suffers as a Christian, let him not be ashamed, but let him glorify God in that name.” The statement that judgment begins at the household of God (4:17) reminds us that God refines his own people first. Those who suffer according to God’s will should entrust their souls to a faithful Creator while doing good.

In chapter 5, Peter, “a fellow elder and a witness of the sufferings of Christ,” speaks to elders: “Shepherd the flock of God that is among you, exercising oversight, not under compulsion, but willingly, as God would have you; not for shameful gain, but eagerly; not domineering over those in your charge, but being examples to the flock. And when the chief Shepherd appears, you will receive the unfading crown of glory.” The younger are to be subject to the

elders. All are to clothe themselves with humility, “for God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble.” “Humble yourselves, therefore, under the mighty hand of God so that at the proper time he may exalt you, casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you.”

The final warning: “Be sober-minded; be watchful. Your adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour. Resist him, firm in your faith, knowing that the same kinds of suffering are being experienced by your brotherhood throughout the world.” The devil is real and fierce, but he is a lion on a leash. Then comes the promise: “And after you have suffered a little while, the God of all grace, who has called you to his eternal glory in Christ, will himself restore, confirm, strengthen, and establish you. To him be the dominion forever and ever. Amen.” Peter signs off with greetings from Silvanus, from “she who is at Babylon” (the church in Rome), and from Mark, his son in the faith, with a final blessing: “Peace to all of you who are in Christ.”

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 12:6-8 and 1 Corinthians 12 discuss spiritual gifts. Proverbs 10:12 is behind 4:8. Matthew 5:10-12 blesses those persecuted. Acts 5:41 shows the apostles rejoicing in suffering. Philippians 3:10 speaks of sharing Christ’s sufferings. Ezekiel 9:6 and Malachi 3:1-6 relate to judgment beginning at God’s house. John 21:15-17 records Peter’s commission to feed the sheep. Ezekiel 34 and John 10 speak of shepherds. Psalm 55:22 is the source of 5:7. Job 1-2 shows Satan with limits. James 4:6-10 has a similar sequence of humility and resisting the devil.

STEP 6

Application

Identify a gift God has given you, and put it to use in your church this week.

If you are in a hard season, repeat 5:7 and name the specific worry that you are handing to God.

Ask whether you are “watchful” or complacent. What habit would help you stay alert and resist the devil?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Cast your anxieties on God, and name them.

Ask him to help you resist the devil and stand firm.

Thank him for the grace that called you to eternal glory.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 122

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

2 PETER 3:18

DAY 850 · WEEK 122

2 Peter 1:1-21

The divine nature; the prophetic word confirmed

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Peter 1:1-21. This letter is Peter's last testimony, written as his death approaches. Notice the great promises, the call to grow, and the confidence he gives in the apostolic witness and the prophetic word.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Peter writes his second letter shortly before his martyrdom, probably in the mid-60s AD. He knows that "the putting off of my body will be soon" (1:14), just as the Lord Jesus told him. His readers are in danger of false teachers who would draw them from the truth, so Peter wants to remind them of what they know. He calls himself Simeon Peter, a servant and apostle, and begins with the foundation of the whole Christian life: what God has already given us in Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "To those who have obtained a faith of equal standing with ours" (1:1).
2. "His divine power has granted to us all things that pertain to life and godliness" (1:3).
3. "That through them you may become partakers of the divine nature" (1:4).
4. "Make every effort to supplement your faith with virtue" (1:5).
5. "Be all the more diligent to make your calling and election sure" (1:10).
6. "For we did not follow cleverly devised myths when we made known to you the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ, but we were eyewitnesses of his majesty" (1:16).
7. "And we have something more sure, the prophetic word, to which you will do well to pay attention as to a lamp shining in a dark place" (1:19).

8 “Men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit” (1:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter greets those who have received “a faith of equal standing with ours,” which is to say the same faith that the apostles have, through the righteousness of “our God and Savior Jesus Christ.” Peter again calls Jesus God. Then he lays the foundation: “His divine power has granted to us all things that pertain to life and godliness, through the knowledge of him who called us to his own glory and excellence, by which he has granted to us his precious and very great promises, so that through them you may become partakers of the divine nature, having escaped from the corruption that is in the world because of sinful desire.” Everything we need has already been given. To be a “partaker of the divine nature” does not mean we become God. The best reading is that, by union with Christ, we share in his moral likeness and the life he gives, escaping the corruption of sin. We are reborn into a new life and will be made like him.

Since God has given everything, Peter urges effort: “For this very reason, make every effort to supplement your faith with virtue, and virtue with knowledge, and knowledge with self-control, and self-control with steadfastness, and steadfastness with godliness, and godliness with brotherly affection, and brotherly affection with love.” It is a ladder of growth with faith at the base and love at the top. “For if these qualities are yours and are increasing, they keep you from being ineffective or unfruitful in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ.” The one who lacks them is nearsighted and has forgotten that he was cleansed from his former sins. “Therefore, brothers, be all the more diligent to make your calling and election sure, for if you practice these qualities you will never fall.” We do not make God’s election sure; we make it sure to us, confirming it by a transformed life. Then an entrance into the eternal kingdom will be supplied.

Peter then explains why he is writing. Soon he will die, and he wants them to remember these things. He does not rely on cleverly devised myths: “we were eyewitnesses of his majesty.” He was with Jesus on the mount of transfiguration and heard the voice from heaven: “This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased.” That experience confirmed the Old Testament prophets’ message: “And we have something more sure, the prophetic word, to which you will do well to pay attention as to a lamp shining in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts.”

Finally, Peter tells us how to understand Scripture: “knowing this first of all, that no prophecy of Scripture comes from someone’s own interpretation. For no prophecy was ever produced by the will of man, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy

Spirit." The point is about the origin of Scripture, not about private reading. The writers were human, but the Holy Spirit carried them, as a ship is carried by wind, so what they wrote is God's word. We examine this more on Day 851.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 17:1-8 records the transfiguration that Peter witnessed. John 21:18-19 records Jesus' prediction of Peter's death. Romans 8:28-30 speaks of calling and election. Galatians 5:22-23 lists the fruit of the Spirit. Colossians 1:10 calls for growth in the knowledge of God. Titus 3:5-7 and 1 John 3:2 speak of new birth and being like Christ. Psalm 119:105 describes the word as a lamp. Revelation 22:16 calls Christ the bright morning star. 2 Timothy 3:16 speaks of the inspiration of Scripture. 2 Timothy 4:6-8 is Paul's parallel farewell.

STEP 6

Application

Write out the seven qualities in verses 5 to 7 and rate yourself on each. Choose one to work on this week.

Memorize 1:3 and remind yourself that you already have everything you need for life and godliness in Christ.

Read the Bible today with a lamp-in-the-dark expectation: God will shed light on something.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for giving you everything you need for life and godliness.

Ask him to help you grow in virtue and knowledge.

Thank him for the prophetic word as a lamp.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 122

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

2 PETER 3:18

DAY 851 · WEEK 122

2 Peter 1:16-21; 2 Peter 3:15-16

Why these 66 books

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Doctrine · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Peter 1:16-21 and 2 Peter 3:15-16. Today is a doctrinal pause on the Bible itself: where it came from, why we have these sixty-six books, and why we trust them. Notice that Peter calls Paul's letters Scripture.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Christians believe the Bible is God's word, but where did the list of books come from? Who decided which were included? Were they chosen by councils or simply recognized? These questions matter, especially for new believers who may hear that the Bible was assembled by powerful men centuries after Jesus. The answer is that the church recognized books that already carried God's authority. Peter's letter gives us early evidence of this process.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For we did not follow cleverly devised myths" (2 Peter 1:16).
2. "And we have something more sure, the prophetic word" (2 Peter 1:19).
3. "No prophecy of Scripture comes from someone's own interpretation" (2 Peter 1:20).
4. "For no prophecy was ever produced by the will of man, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit" (2 Peter 1:21).
5. "Our beloved brother Paul also wrote to you according to the wisdom given him" (2 Peter 3:15).
6. "There are some things in them that are hard to understand" (2 Peter 3:16).
7. "Which the ignorant and unstable twist to their own destruction, as they do the other Scriptures" (2 Peter 3:16).

8 “And count the patience of our Lord as salvation” (2 Peter 3:15).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Bible is a library of sixty-six books: thirty-nine in the Old Testament and twenty-seven in the New, written over about fifteen hundred years by some forty human authors. Yet it is one story, because it has one divine author. Peter says that “men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit.” The human writers used their own personalities, styles, and research, and yet the product is God’s word. This is called inspiration. Because God is truthful, Scripture is also inerrant in what it affirms and sufficient for faith and life.

What is the canon? The word means “rule” or “standard.” The canon is the list of books recognized as the authoritative word of God. The church did not create the canon; it recognized it. Just as a person does not make a gold coin real by testing it, the church discerned which writings bore the marks of God’s voice.

The Old Testament canon. The Jewish community recognized the Law, the Prophets, and the Writings. Jesus and the apostles treated these as Scripture. Jesus spoke of “the Law of Moses and the Prophets and the Psalms” (Luke 24:44) and referred to the span from Abel to Zechariah (Luke 11:51), which covers the Hebrew Bible from first to last. The New Testament quotes nearly every book of the Old Testament as authoritative. The books called the Apocrypha or deuterocanonical books (Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, 1-2 Maccabees, and others) were written in the period between the testaments. The Roman Catholic Church formally included most of them at the Council of Trent in 1546, and Eastern Orthodox churches also include some. Protestants, following the Hebrew canon recognized by Jesus’ contemporaries, do not accept them as Scripture, though many find them useful for history. Those who hold to the Reformation view note that these books are never quoted as Scripture by Jesus or the apostles.

The New Testament canon. Early Christians recognized three features: apostolic origin (written by an apostle or someone connected to an apostle’s authority), conformity to the apostolic teaching, and widespread, continuous use in the churches. The four Gospels and Paul’s letters were widely accepted very early. Peter himself refers to Paul’s letters alongside “the other Scriptures” (2 Peter 3:16), showing that within the lifetime of the apostles, their writings were beginning to be received as Scripture. Lists from the second century (such as the Muratorian fragment) already resemble ours. Athanasius in AD 367 listed the twenty-seven books, and councils at Hippo (393) and Carthage (397) affirmed them. These councils confirmed what the churches already knew.

Why trust it? We believe the Bible is God's word because of its own testimony, the witness of the Holy Spirit in believers, the character of Christ it reveals, its internal unity, and its historical reliability. And Jesus himself trusted the Scriptures: "Scripture cannot be broken" (John 10:35). If we trust Jesus, we trust the book he trusted. Because the apostles carry the authority he gave them, their writings complete the witness.

Peter also warns that Scripture can be twisted. Some of Paul's letters are hard to understand, and the ignorant and unstable twist them. We should read with humility, compare Scripture with Scripture, and seek help from the church.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter's first claim (1:16-18) is that the apostolic message is rooted in history. They did not follow clever myths. They were eyewitnesses. This is a concern about the truth of what happened, and it is the basis for the New Testament's authority.

The second claim (1:19-21) is that the Old Testament prophets spoke by God. The verb "carried along" is the same used of a ship driven by the wind in Acts 27:15. The Spirit moved the authors, so that their words were truly theirs and truly God's. The statement that no prophecy comes "from someone's own interpretation" is best understood to mean that no prophet made up his message; the origin is God, not the prophet's own insight. It also reminds us that interpretation matters: we should not twist Scripture to say what we want.

The third claim (3:15-16) is that Paul's letters are among "the other Scriptures." This is a remarkable thing for one apostle to say of another. It is also worth noting the humility of Peter: he admits some things in Paul are "hard to understand." Even apostles had to wrestle with Scripture, which should encourage us when we find it hard.

Practically, this teaches us three things. First, we can trust the Bible because it comes from God. Second, we should study it carefully, because errors in interpretation have real consequences. Third, we should read it in the community of the church, where gifted teachers help us understand it.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Timothy 3:16-17 and Hebrews 1:1-2 speak of God's word through prophets and his Son. Luke 24:25-27 and 24:44-47 show Jesus reading the Old Testament about himself. John 10:35 says Scripture cannot be broken. Matthew 5:17-18 affirms the Law and the Prophets. John 14:26 and 16:13 promise the Spirit's help to the apostles. 1 Thessalonians 2:13 says the word is

received as the word of God. 1 Timothy 5:18 quotes Luke as Scripture. Revelation 22:18-19 warns against adding to or taking away. Psalm 19:7-11 praises the word of the LORD. Acts 8:30-35 shows Philip explaining Scripture.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God today for the Bible and for the people who preserved and translated it.

If you have doubts about the Bible's reliability, write down your questions and bring them to a pastor or a trusted friend. Many good books address them.

Read one passage this week that is "hard to understand," and use a study Bible or commentary to help.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for giving you his word through the prophets and apostles.

Ask him to help you trust it as his word.

Ask him to give you a hunger for all of it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 122

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

2 PETER 3:18

DAY 852 · WEEK 122

2 Peter 2:1-3:18

False teachers; the day of the Lord

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 40 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Peter 2:1-3:18. The first chapter warns against false teachers, and the second looks ahead to the day of the Lord. Notice Peter's use of Old Testament examples and his answer to the scoffers who ask, "Where is the promise of his coming?"

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Peter's readers were threatened by false teachers who were morally lax and who mocked the idea that Christ would return. Peter's response is stern about the teachers (chapter 2) and pastoral toward the believers (chapter 3). The letter has many similarities to Jude, and many scholars think Peter and Jude drew on a common warning. The second chapter is among the strongest descriptions of false teaching in the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "There will be false teachers among you, who will secretly bring in destructive heresies" (2:1).
2. "Then the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from trials" (2:9).
3. "Scoffers will come in the last days with scoffing" (3:3).
4. "Where is the promise of his coming?" (3:4).
5. "With the Lord one day is as a thousand years, and a thousand years as one day" (3:8).
6. "The Lord is not slow to fulfill his promise as some count slowness, but is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance" (3:9).

7. “According to his promise we are waiting for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells” (3:13).

8. “But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ” (3:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter says that just as false prophets arose in Israel, “there will be false teachers among you, who will secretly bring in destructive heresies, even denying the Master who bought them, bringing upon themselves swift destruction.” They are known by their doctrine and their lives: many will follow their sensuality, and because of them the way of truth will be blasphemed. They exploit others with false words. But judgment is certain. Peter gives three examples: the angels who sinned and were cast into hell, the ancient world destroyed by the flood (with Noah preserved as a herald of righteousness), and Sodom and Gomorrah (with Lot rescued). “Then the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from trials, and to keep the unrighteous under punishment until the day of judgment.” God both saves and judges.

The false teachers are described vividly: following the flesh in corrupt desire, despising authority, bold and willful, “like irrational animals.” They are “springs without water and mists driven by a storm.” They promise freedom, “but they themselves are slaves of corruption.” Peter says it would have been better never to have known the way of righteousness than to turn back from it, as a dog returns to its vomit and a washed sow to wallowing in the mire.

Chapter 3 begins with a reminder. Peter writes to stir up their sincere minds to remember the words of the prophets and the apostles. “Knowing this first of all, that scoffers will come in the last days with scoffing, following their own sinful desires. They will say, Where is the promise of his coming? For ever since the fathers fell asleep, all things are continuing as they were from the beginning of creation.” Peter answers: they forget that God created the world by his word, and that the same word destroyed the world by water and now holds the present heavens and earth for fire. Delay is not slowness. “With the Lord one day is as a thousand years, and a thousand years as one day.” God is not bound by our clock. “The Lord is not slow to fulfill his promise as some count slowness, but is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance.” Delay is mercy. Christians who hold to unconditional election read “you” as the elect, God’s people, for whom he waits until all are gathered. Others read “all” broadly as God’s desire for every person. Either way, patience calls for repentance.

“But the day of the Lord will come like a thief, and then the heavens will pass away with a roar, and the elements will be dissolved with heat, and the earth and the works that are done on it will be exposed.” Interpreters debate whether this means the complete destruction of

the present creation or its purging and renewal by fire, as metal is refined. Many hold the latter, noting the comparison to Noah's flood, which did not annihilate the earth. The end result is clear: "According to his promise we are waiting for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells."

So what kind of people should we be? "Since all these things are thus to be dissolved, what sort of people ought you to be in lives of holiness and godliness, waiting for and hastening the coming of the day of God?" Be diligent to be found without spot or blemish, at peace. Beware of being carried away with the error of lawless people. And the closing charge: "But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

STEP 5

Connection

Jude 4-19 closely parallels chapter 2. Genesis 6-8 and 19 record the flood and Sodom. Numbers 22-24 tells the story of Balaam. Proverbs 26:11 is quoted in 2:22. Psalm 90:4 stands behind 3:8. Matthew 24:36-44 and 1 Thessalonians 5:2 describe the Lord coming like a thief. Habakkuk 2:3 speaks of waiting for a delayed vision. Romans 2:4 says God's kindness leads to repentance. 1 Timothy 2:4 says God desires all to be saved. Isaiah 65:17 and 66:22 promise new heavens and a new earth. Romans 8:19-23 and Revelation 21:1-5 describe the renewed creation.

STEP 6

Application

Test the teaching you hear against Scripture. Ask where it comes from, what it says about Christ, and what kind of lives its teachers lead.

Reframe a delay in your own life, such as an unanswered prayer or a waiting season, in light of 3:8-9. How might God be showing patience?

Pick one way to "grow in grace and knowledge" this week, such as a book of the Bible or a theological book.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you from false teachers.

Thank him that he knows how to rescue the godly.

Ask him to help you grow in grace and in knowledge of Jesus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 122

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

2 PETER 3:18

DAY 853 · WEEK 122

Psalm 34

Taste and see that the LORD is good

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 34. David praises God for rescue and invites others to taste and see. Notice the movement from personal testimony to teaching, and the promises to the brokenhearted and the righteous.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The heading says this is a psalm "of David, when he changed his behavior before Abimelech, so that he drove him out, and he went away." It looks back on 1 Samuel 21:10-15, when David, fleeing Saul, went to the Philistine king and pretended to be insane to save his life. The psalm is an acrostic, each verse beginning with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It is a thanksgiving for deliverance and a teaching psalm. Peter quotes it in his first letter (1 Peter 2:3 and 3:10-12), so it is a natural companion to our reading.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will bless the LORD at all times; his praise shall continually be in my mouth" (v. 1).
2. "I sought the LORD, and he answered me and delivered me from all my fears" (v. 4).
3. "Those who look to him are radiant, and their faces shall never be ashamed" (v. 5).
4. "The angel of the LORD encamps around those who fear him, and delivers them" (v. 7).
5. "Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!" (v. 8).
6. "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted and saves the crushed in spirit" (v. 18).
7. "Many are the afflictions of the righteous, but the LORD delivers him out of them all" (v. 19).

8 “The LORD redeems the life of his servants; none of those who take refuge in him will be condemned” (v. 22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David begins with a commitment: “I will bless the LORD at all times; his praise shall continually be in my mouth.” Not only when things go well, and not only when he is in the temple. This praise comes from a man who has just escaped by his wits and who admits that the credit belongs to the LORD. He invites others: “Oh, magnify the LORD with me, and let us exalt his name together!” Then his story: “I sought the LORD, and he answered me and delivered me from all my fears.” This poor man (the afflicted) cried, and the LORD heard him and saved him out of all his troubles. “The angel of the LORD encamps around those who fear him, and delivers them.”

The center of the psalm is the invitation: “Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!” Faith is not only believing; it is experiencing. We do not just analyze whether a meal is good; we taste it. God invites us to try him and find that he is good. Peter picks up the image in 1 Peter 2:3, speaking of those who have “tasted that the Lord is good.” David notes that young lions suffer want and hunger, “but those who seek the LORD lack no good thing.”

Then David moves into a teaching mode: “Come, O children, listen to me; I will teach you the fear of the LORD.” The fear of the LORD includes keeping the tongue from evil, turning from evil and doing good, and seeking peace. “The eyes of the LORD are toward the righteous and his ears toward their cry. The face of the LORD is against those who do evil.” Peter quotes these verses to encourage persecuted Christians that God sees their suffering.

The psalm’s most tender promise is verse 18: “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted and saves the crushed in spirit.” God does not stand far off from the hurting. And it is honest about suffering: “Many are the afflictions of the righteous, but the LORD delivers him out of them all. He keeps all his bones; not one of them is broken.” John quotes this verse in John 19:36, seeing it fulfilled in Jesus on the cross: not one of his bones was broken. The righteous sufferer ultimately is Christ. And the psalm ends with the promise to all who trust in him: “The LORD redeems the life of his servants; none of those who take refuge in him will be condemned.”

STEP 5

Connection

1 Samuel 21:10-15 is the background story. 1 Peter 2:3 and 3:10-12 quote and allude to this psalm. John 19:36 sees verse 20 fulfilled. Psalm 27:13 and 119:103 also speak of tasting God's goodness. Isaiah 57:15 and 61:1 speak of the brokenhearted. Psalm 51:17 says God does not despise a broken heart. Luke 4:18 has Jesus bind up the brokenhearted. Romans 8:1 and 8:31-39 declare no condemnation. Matthew 4:11 and Hebrews 1:14 refer to angels serving. Romans 8:28 says God works for the good of those who love him.

STEP 6

Application

Practice taste and see: pause at one point today and thank God for something specific, noticing his goodness.

If you are brokenhearted, read verse 18 slowly and pray it as your own. If you know someone who is, sit with them.

Tell someone else about a time God delivered you, as David did in verses 1 to 6.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bless the LORD at this moment, in your own words.
- Thank him for delivering you from fears.
- Ask him to help you taste and see his goodness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 122

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

2 PETER 3:18

DAY 854 · WEEK 122

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Peter 3:18 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

2 PETER 3:18

REST

Meditation

These are Peter's last written words, and they are a command to keep growing. After warnings about false teachers and scoffers, his remedy is not only to guard but to grow. A healthy plant resists disease. A Christian who grows in grace and knowledge is harder to lead astray.

Grace comes first. We grow in the grace of God, receiving more of his kindness and being shaped by it. Knowledge comes second: not just information, but knowing Christ more deeply. The two go together; knowledge without grace puffs up, and grace without knowledge stays shallow.

Notice the object: "our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ." Growth is growth toward and into him. And the verse ends with praise: "To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity." Our growth is for his glory. Ask the Lord today where he wants you to grow.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the rest of 1 Peter and all of 2 Peter. First Peter 2 and 3 called us to honor everyone, follow the example of Christ who bore our sins on the tree, and always be ready to explain our hope with gentleness and respect. First Peter 4 and 5 taught us to love earnestly, use our gifts as good stewards, not be surprised by fiery trials, shepherd willingly, cast our anxieties on God, resist the roaring lion, and trust the God of all grace. Second Peter 1 told us that God has given us everything we need for life and godliness and urged us to add virtue to our faith. On Day 851 we paused on the origin and canon of Scripture. Second Peter 2 and 3 warned us about false teachers and scoffers and pointed to the patience of the Lord and the new heavens and new earth. Psalm 34 invited us to taste and see that the LORD is good.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Peter says to be ready to give a defense for the hope that is in you with gentleness and respect. What is your hope, and how would you explain it in two minutes to a neighbor who asked?

Peter says to cast all your anxieties on God because he cares for you. What anxiety are you carrying right now? What would it look like to hand it to him in prayer today?

Peter's final words are to grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. In what area do you most want to grow in the next month, and what is one practical step?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for rest and for his word.

Ask him to help you grow in grace and knowledge.

Rest in his provision.

DAY 855 · WEEK 123

Psalm 118:1-18

His steadfast love endures forever

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 118:1-18. This is the last of the Hallel psalms (113 to 118), which Jews sang at Passover and which Jesus and his disciples most likely sang at the Last Supper. Notice how often the psalm repeats "the LORD" and how the speaker moves from distress to victory.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 118 is a song of thanksgiving for a national and personal deliverance, sung in procession to the temple. The speaker is a king or leader who has been surrounded by enemies and brought through. The Hallel was sung at the great feasts, and the New Testament treats this psalm as pointing to Christ: the stone the builders rejected (v. 22) and "Blessed is he who comes in the name of the LORD" (v. 26) were cried at Jesus' entry into Jerusalem. Today we read the first part, which focuses on God's steadfast love and salvation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!" (v. 1).
2. "Out of my distress I called on the LORD; the LORD answered me and set me free" (v. 5).
3. "The LORD is on my side; I will not fear. What can man do to me?" (v. 6).
4. "It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man" (v. 8).
5. "All nations surrounded me; in the name of the LORD I cut them off!" (v. 10).
6. "I was pushed hard, so that I was falling, but the LORD helped me" (v. 13).
7. "The LORD is my strength and my song; he has become my salvation" (v. 14).
8. "I shall not die, but I shall live, and recount the deeds of the LORD" (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins and ends with the same words: “Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!” Israel, the house of Aaron, and all who fear the LORD are called to say it. “Steadfast love” (hesed) is God’s covenant faithfulness, a love that does not let go. It is the refrain of the exodus and of the whole Old Testament. Later we will read in 1 John that “God is love,” and the two belong together. The love that endures forever is the love that sent the Son.

Then the testimony: “Out of my distress I called on the LORD; the LORD answered me and set me free.” The Hebrew for “set me free” is “in a broad place,” meaning out of tight distress into open space. From this the singer draws a conclusion: “The LORD is on my side; I will not fear. What can man do to me?” Paul takes up the same confidence in Romans 8:31: “If God is for us, who can be against us?” The LORD is my helper, and I shall look in triumph on those who hate me. Then a proverb: “It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man. It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in princes.” Human help is limited; God’s help is not.

Verses 10 to 12 describe the enemies swarming like bees, flaming like a fire of thorns. Three times the singer says, “In the name of the LORD I cut them off.” Victory is not in his strength but in God’s name. Then verse 13 is honest about how close it was: “I was pushed hard, so that I was falling, but the LORD helped me.” We should not minimize the near-failure. And at the center, a line borrowed from the Song of Moses (Exodus 15:2): “The LORD is my strength and my song; he has become my salvation.” Glad songs of salvation are heard in the tents of the righteous: “The right hand of the LORD does valiantly.”

The speaker concludes this section with a statement of resurrection language: “I shall not die, but I shall live, and recount the deeds of the LORD. The LORD has disciplined me severely, but he has not given me over to death.” He has been chastened but not condemned. For the singer, it is deliverance from literal death; for Christians, it points to Christ, who died and rose, and to all who are in him. He sang this psalm on the night he was betrayed, knowing what lay ahead. And the God whose love endures forever did not abandon him to the grave.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 15:2 is quoted in verse 14. Psalm 56:4, 11 and Romans 8:31 echo verse 6. Jeremiah 17:5-8 contrasts trust in man and trust in the LORD. Psalm 146:3 warns against trusting princes. Matthew 26:30 and Mark 14:26 say Jesus and the disciples sang a hymn, probably the

Hallel. Matthew 21:9, 42 apply verses 22 and 26 to Jesus. Acts 4:11 and 1 Peter 2:7 quote verse 22. Hebrews 12:5-11 speaks of the Lord's discipline. 1 John 4:8-10 speaks of God's love. 2 Corinthians 1:8-10 describes deliverance from the sentence of death.

STEP 6

Application

Read verse 1 aloud at the start of the day, and name three specific ways you have seen God's steadfast love in the last week.

Name a person or institution in which you are placing too much trust. Entrust that situation to the LORD.

Memorize verse 14 as a short prayer when you feel weak.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Give thanks to God for his steadfast love.
- Thank him that the LORD is on your side.
- Thank him for the stone the builders rejected.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 123

"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."

1 JOHN 1:9

DAY 856 · WEEK 123

Psalm 31:1-8

Into your hands I commit my spirit

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 31:1-8. This is a prayer of refuge by David. Notice the rock and fortress language and the line that Jesus prayed from the cross.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 31 is a psalm of David written in a time of distress, perhaps when he was hunted by Saul. It contains a mixture of confident trust, honest lament, and thanksgiving. The first eight verses are mostly trust. Verse 5 holds special significance because Jesus used it as his final prayer on the cross (Luke 23:46), and so did Stephen as he died (Acts 7:59). Many saints through history have prayed it at the end of their lives.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “In you, O LORD, do I take refuge; let me never be put to shame; in your righteousness deliver me!” (v. 1).
2. “Be a rock of refuge for me, a strong fortress to save me!” (v. 2).
3. “For you are my rock and my fortress” (v. 3).
4. “You take me out of the net they have hidden for me, for you are my refuge” (v. 4).
5. “Into your hand I commit my spirit; you have redeemed me, O LORD, faithful God” (v. 5).
6. “But I trust in the LORD” (v. 6).
7. “I will rejoice and be glad in your steadfast love, because you have seen my affliction” (v. 7).
8. “You have set my feet in a broad place” (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David begins with a plea built on God's character: "In you, O LORD, do I take refuge; let me never be put to shame; in your righteousness deliver me!" He appeals not to his own righteousness but to God's. He asks God to incline his ear, to rescue speedily, and to be a rock of refuge and a strong fortress. Then he states a conviction: "For you are my rock and my fortress; and for your name's sake you lead me and guide me." God's reputation is bound up with his people. Because his name is good, he can be trusted to guide.

The enemies have set a trap: "You take me out of the net they have hidden for me, for you are my refuge." David is not just fleeing; he is looking to God to pull him from danger he cannot see.

Then the line that has comforted generations: "Into your hand I commit my spirit; you have redeemed me, O LORD, faithful God." For David, it was a prayer of trust at a time of danger, committing his life into God's hand. It is a daily prayer, like a rest at night. And since Jesus prayed it at his death (adding "Father"), it became the prayer of the dying. When Jesus said it, he was committing himself into the hands of the Father who would raise him. For the believer, to commit our spirit to God is to trust him with our life now and our death at the end.

David contrasts his trust with that of those who "pay regard to worthless idols." Idols cannot rescue. He rejoices in God's steadfast love, "because you have seen my affliction; you have known the distress of my soul, and you have not delivered me into the hand of the enemy; you have set my feet in a broad place." God sees, knows, and brings out into the open. The tightness of danger gives way to wide places.

Verses 9 to 18 turn to lament, describing David's grief, his friends' abandonment, and his plot-ridden enemies. There David says, "But I trust in you, O LORD; I say, You are my God. My times are in your hand" (vv. 14-15). The psalm ends with a call to the saints to love the LORD and to be strong and take courage, all you who wait for him (vv. 23-24).

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 23:46 and Acts 7:59 quote verse 5. Psalm 18:2, 71:1-3, and 91:2 use rock and fortress language. Psalm 25:2-3 also asks not to be put to shame. Psalm 18:19 and 118:5 speak of a broad place. Jonah 2:8 also refers to idols. Isaiah 41:10 and Romans 8:31-39 offer similar assurance. 1 Peter 4:19 speaks of entrusting our souls to a faithful Creator. Hebrews 5:7-9 speaks of Jesus' prayers. John 10:28-29 speaks of being held in the hand of Jesus and the Father. 2 Timothy 1:12 expresses a similar confidence in what Christ guards.

STEP 6

Application

Pray verse 5 tonight as you go to sleep, committing your spirit and tomorrow into God's hand.

Think of a situation that feels like a tight place. Ask God to set your feet in a broad place.

If you are afraid of death, memorize verse 5 and remember who prayed it first.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Take refuge in God, and tell him why.
- Commit your spirit into his hands.
- Ask him to lead and guide you for his name's sake.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 123

"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."

1 JOHN 1:9

DAY 857 · WEEK 123

1 John 1:1-2:29

The word of life; walking in light; the antichrists

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 John 1:1-2:29. John writes as an eyewitness of Jesus and gives tests by which his readers can know that they have eternal life. Notice the repeated themes of light and darkness, truth and lies, and love and hate.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The apostle John, the last living eyewitness, wrote this letter in his old age, probably from Ephesus in the 80s or 90s AD. A group had left the church (2:19), claiming a higher knowledge, denying that Jesus had come in the flesh, and living as though sin did not matter. John writes to assure true believers and expose the counterfeit. There is no formal greeting; he begins like a sermon. His message is simple and deep: the God who is light and love has come to us in Jesus, and those who know him walk in the light and love one another.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “That which we have heard, which we have seen with our eyes, which we looked upon and have touched with our hands” (1:1).
2. “God is light, and in him is no darkness at all” (1:5).
3. “The blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin” (1:7).
4. “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness” (1:9).
5. “We have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous” (2:1).
6. “He is the propitiation for our sins” (2:2).
7. “Do not love the world or the things in the world” (2:15).

8 “They went out from us, but they were not of us” (2:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John begins by insisting that the Word of life was heard, seen, and touched. The Christian faith is not a myth or an idea but the testimony of those who handled the incarnate Son. The purpose of this witness is fellowship: “that you too may have fellowship with us; and indeed our fellowship is with the Father and with his Son Jesus Christ.” He writes “that our joy may be complete.”

The message is this: “God is light, and in him is no darkness at all.” Then John gives three false claims and three true responses. If we claim fellowship with him while walking in darkness, we lie. But “if we walk in the light, as he is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin.” If we say we have no sin, we deceive ourselves. But “if we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.” He is faithful (he keeps his promises) and just (the price was paid by Christ). If we say we have not sinned, we make him a liar. Walking in the light does not mean sinless perfection; it means honest confession.

Chapter 2 opens tenderly. “My little children, I am writing these things to you so that you may not sin. But if anyone does sin, we have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous. He is the propitiation for our sins, and not for ours only but also for the sins of the whole world.” Propitiation means the sacrifice that turns aside God’s wrath. Christ is both the advocate who pleads for us and the sacrifice that makes the plea valid. The phrase “the whole world” has been understood in different ways: that Christ’s sacrifice is sufficient for all and sincerely offered to all, or (as many Reformed interpreters hold) that it is for people from every nation and not for Jews only. Either way, the focus is on the sufficiency and reach of his work.

The tests of knowing God are obedience and love. “And by this we know that we have come to know him, if we keep his commandments.” Whoever says he abides in him ought to walk as he walked. The old commandment is a new commandment that is true in Christ: whoever loves his brother abides in the light; whoever hates his brother is in darkness. John then addresses children, fathers, and young men with a message of forgiveness, knowledge of him who is from the beginning, and victory over the evil one.

The second warning is against the world: “Do not love the world or the things in the world. If anyone loves the world, the love of the Father is not in him. For all that is in the world, the desires of the flesh and the desires of the eyes and pride in possessions, is not from the Father but is from the world. And the world is passing away along with its desires, but whoever does the will of God abides forever.”

The final section warns about antichrists. “Children, it is the last hour, and as you have heard that antichrist is coming, so now many antichrists have come.” The last hour began with Christ’s first coming. The antichrists denied that Jesus is the Christ. “They went out from us, but they were not of us; for if they had been of us, they would have continued with us. But they went out, so that it might become plain that they all are not of us.” Departure revealed their true nature. By contrast, believers have an anointing from the Holy One and know the truth. John exhorts: “And now, little children, abide in him, so that when he appears we may have confidence and not shrink from him in shame at his coming.”

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:1-14 and Luke 24:39 relate to the eyewitness testimony. Psalm 32:1-5 and Proverbs 28:13 speak of confession. Romans 3:25 and Hebrews 2:17 use propitiation language. Romans 8:34 and Hebrews 7:25 describe Christ’s intercession. John 13:34-35 gives the new commandment. Genesis 3:6 echoes the three desires in 2:16. Matthew 24:24 and 2 Thessalonians 2 speak of antichrists. John 14:26 and 16:13 promise the Spirit as teacher. Hebrews 6:4-6 and 10:26-31 speak of falling away. John 6:66-69 shows disciples who left Jesus.

STEP 6

Application

Confess a specific sin today. Believe the promise of 1:9 and receive the forgiveness: he is faithful and just.

When you sin this week, remember you have an advocate. Run to him, not away.

Examine your loves. What “world” desire has been competing with the love of the Father?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is light, and ask him to help you walk in it.

Confess your sin and thank him for forgiving it.

Ask him to keep you from loving the world.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 123

“If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.”

1 JOHN 1:9

DAY 858 · WEEK 123

1 John 3:1-24

Children of God; love as the test of genuine faith

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 John 3:1-24. John speaks of the great love of the Father, the family likeness of God's children, and love as the test of life. Notice the contrast between the children of God and the children of the devil.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In this chapter John continues his tests of genuine faith. These tests are not given to make believers anxious but to give assurance. Those who have been born of God will show a family likeness: they practice righteousness, they turn from sin, and they love their brothers and sisters. Cain is the example of the opposite. At the center is the cross as the pattern of love.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "See what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God; and so we are" (v. 1).
2. "When he appears we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is" (v. 2).
3. "The reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the works of the devil" (v. 8).
4. "No one born of God makes a practice of sinning" (v. 9).
5. "We know that we have passed out of death into life, because we love the brothers" (v. 14).
6. "By this we know love, that he laid down his life for us, and we ought to lay down our lives for the brothers" (v. 16).
7. "Little children, let us not love in word or talk but in deed and in truth" (v. 18).

8 “For whenever our heart condemns us, God is greater than our heart, and he knows everything” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John begins with amazement: “See what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God; and so we are.” We are not just treated as children; we are children. The world does not recognize us, because it did not know him. And the future is greater: “Beloved, we are God’s children now, and what we will be has not yet appeared; but we know that when he appears we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is. And everyone who thus hopes in him purifies himself as he is pure.” The hope of seeing Christ and being like him is a power for holiness now.

Then comes the connection between sin and the new birth. “Everyone who makes a practice of sinning also practices lawlessness; sin is lawlessness.” Christ appeared to take away sins, and in him there is no sin. “The reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the works of the devil.” Then the verse that has puzzled many: “No one born of God makes a practice of sinning, for God’s seed abides in him, and he cannot keep on sinning because he has been born of God.” Taken alone it seems to teach sinless perfection, but John already said in 1:8 that anyone who claims to be without sin is a liar. The verbs in the Greek are in the present tense and describe continuous, habitual action. A child of God may sin but cannot settle into sin as a way of life, because a new nature has been planted in him. So the children of God and the children of the devil are manifest: “Whoever does not practice righteousness is not of God, nor is the one who does not love his brother.”

The message from the beginning: “that we should love one another.” Not like Cain, who murdered his brother because his deeds were evil. “Do not be surprised, brothers, that the world hates you.” And then: “We know that we have passed out of death into life, because we love the brothers. Whoever does not love abides in death.” The Christian does not love in order to receive life; love is the evidence that life has been received.

The definition of love is the cross: “By this we know love, that he laid down his life for us, and we ought to lay down our lives for the brothers.” This leads to a very practical word: “But if anyone has the world’s goods and sees his brother in need, yet closes his heart against him, how does God’s love abide in him? Little children, let us not love in word or talk but in deed and in truth.” By this, we know that we are of the truth and reassure our heart before him.

Then a pastoral comfort for troubled consciences: “For whenever our heart condemns us, God is greater than our heart, and he knows everything.” Some read this as comfort: even when our conscience accuses us, God knows our sincere desire to love him and is greater than our accusing heart. Others read it as a warning that God sees all. In context, comfort is

the more natural meaning. The chapter ends with the twin commands: “that we believe in the name of his Son Jesus Christ and love one another.” And the one who keeps his commandments abides in God, and God in him, and “we know by this that he abides in us, by the Spirit whom he has given us.”

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:12-13 and Romans 8:14-17 speak of becoming children of God. Philippians 3:20-21 and Romans 8:29 promise we will be like Christ. Genesis 3:15 and Colossians 2:15 speak of the defeat of the devil. Genesis 4:1-12 is the story of Cain. John 5:24 says believers have passed from death to life. John 15:13 says there is no greater love than laying down one’s life. Romans 5:8 shows God’s love in Christ’s death. Matthew 25:31-46 ties judgment to care for the needy. James 2:15-17 repeats the point about love in deed. Romans 8:1 and 8:16 offer assurance for the condemning heart.

STEP 6

Application

Spend time with verse 1 and let it sink in: you are a child of God. Thank the Father for his lavish love.

Look for one practical way to love “in deed and in truth” this week, perhaps meeting a financial or practical need in your church.

If your heart condemns you, pray verse 20 and rest in God’s greater knowledge and mercy.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the love that makes you his child.
- Ask him to teach you to love in deed and truth.
- Ask him to give you assurance.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 123

“If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.”

1 JOHN 1:9

DAY 859 · WEEK 123

1 John 4:1-5:21

Test the spirits; God is love; assurance

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 John 4:1-5:21. John gives more tests, including testing the spirits, and reaches the heights in his teaching on God's love. The letter ends with a statement of its purpose: that you may know that you have eternal life.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In these chapters John returns to the tests of true faith: believing that Jesus has come in the flesh, loving one another, and obeying God's commands. He is concerned about false prophets who deny the incarnation. He lays out the foundation of Christian love in the character of God and the love of Christ. The letter closes with assurance and the confidence that believers can pray according to God's will.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Beloved, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits to see whether they are from God" (4:1).
2. "Anyone who does not love does not know God, because God is love" (4:8).
3. "In this is love, not that we have loved God but that he loved us and sent his Son to be the propitiation for our sins" (4:10).
4. "There is no fear in love, but perfect love casts out fear" (4:18).
5. "We love because he first loved us" (4:19).
6. "For this is the love of God, that we keep his commandments. And his commandments are not burdensome" (5:3).

7. “I write these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God that you may know that you have eternal life” (5:13).

8. “Little children, keep yourselves from idols” (5:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John tells his readers to test every spirit, because many false prophets are in the world. The test is confessing that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh. Anyone who denies this is the spirit of the antichrist. But “he who is in you is greater than he who is in the world.” This is the first central theme: truth.

The second theme is love. “Beloved, let us love one another, for love is from God, and whoever loves has been born of God and knows God. Anyone who does not love does not know God, because God is love.” This is not just a description of God’s feelings; it is who he is. And where do we see this love? “In this the love of God was made manifest among us, that God sent his only Son into the world, so that we might live through him. In this is love, not that we have loved God but that he loved us and sent his Son to be the propitiation for our sins.” Love begins with God, not with us. And “if God so loved us, we also ought to love one another.” No one has ever seen God, but if we love one another, God abides in us and his love is perfected in us. The Spirit he has given us is the assurance that we abide in him.

Verse 18 is a comfort: “There is no fear in love, but perfect love casts out fear. For fear has to do with punishment, and whoever fears has not been perfected in love.” When we are sure of the Father’s love, we do not fear final punishment. And then the memory verse of the unit: “We love because he first loved us.” Our love is a response. And finally the test: “If anyone says, I love God, and hates his brother, he is a liar; for he who does not love his brother whom he has seen cannot love God whom he has not seen.”

Chapter 5 states that everyone who believes that Jesus is the Christ has been born of God. Love for God means keeping his commandments, “and his commandments are not burdensome. For everyone who has been born of God overcomes the world.” The victory is our faith. Who is it that overcomes the world except the one who believes that Jesus is the Son of God? John then speaks of the three witnesses: the Spirit, the water, and the blood, which agree. Most interpreters understand these as Jesus’ baptism, his death on the cross, and the Spirit’s testimony. (Some older English translations include an additional clause about “the Father, the Word, and the Holy Spirit” in verse 7, which is not found in the earliest Greek manuscripts.)

The great purpose statement: “And this is the testimony, that God gave us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. Whoever has the Son has life; whoever does not have the Son of God does not have life. I write these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God that you may know that you have eternal life.” Assurance is possible, and it is what the whole letter aims at. He then gives confidence in prayer: “if we ask anything according to his will he hears us.” There is mention of a “sin that leads to death” (5:16-17), which interpreters take differently: a persistent, public rejection of Christ, or apostasy, or a sin bringing physical death. The point is that we should pray for our brothers, and that all wrongdoing is sin. We know that everyone born of God does not keep on sinning, that the Son of God keeps him, and that the evil one does not touch him. The final words, “Little children, keep yourselves from idols,” are a call to cling to the true God.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 13:1-5 and 1 Corinthians 12:3 speak of testing prophets. Romans 5:8 and John 3:16 are other statements of God’s love. Exodus 34:6-7 declares God’s steadfast love. Romans 8:15 says we have not received a spirit of fear but of adoption. Matthew 22:36-40 joins loving God and neighbor. John 14:15 says if you love me, you will keep my commandments. Matthew 11:30 speaks of an easy yoke. John 16:33 says Christ has overcome the world. John 20:31 states a similar purpose. Hebrews 6:4-8 and 10:26-31 relate to the sin leading to death. Exodus 20:3-5 forbids idols.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a teaching you recently heard. Test it by what it says about Christ.

Read 4:9-10 again. Whom do you find difficult to love? Ask God to help you love them as he has loved you.

Write down 5:13 on a card and keep it where you see it as a reminder that you can know you have eternal life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is love and sent his Son.

Ask him to help you love because he first loved you.

Ask him to strengthen your assurance.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 123

“If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.”

1 JOHN 1:9

DAY 860 · WEEK 123

John 10:27-30; Romans 8:31-39; 1 John 5:11-13

Perseverance and Assurance

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 10:27-30, Romans 8:31-39, and 1 John 5:11-13. Today is a doctrinal pause on perseverance and assurance. Notice the language of security and the repeated phrase “no one” and “nothing” can separate us from Christ.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Two questions trouble many Christians. First: can a true believer lose his salvation? Second: how can I know that I am really saved? The first is the doctrine of perseverance, and the second is the doctrine of assurance. They are related but distinct. Christians have answered them in different ways, so we proceed carefully and with charity, and we let Scripture speak.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “My sheep hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me” (John 10:27).
2. “I give them eternal life, and they will never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand” (John 10:28).
3. “No one is able to snatch them out of the Father’s hand” (John 10:29).
4. “If God is for us, who can be against us?” (Romans 8:31).
5. “Who shall separate us from the love of Christ?” (Romans 8:35).
6. “Will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:39).
7. “Whoever has the Son has life” (1 John 5:12).

8 “I write these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God that you may know that you have eternal life” (1 John 5:13).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Perseverance of the saints is the teaching that all those truly born again will be kept by God and will persevere in faith to the end. They are kept not by their own strength but by God’s power (1 Peter 1:5). Those who fall away finally show they were never truly of us (1 John 2:19). This is the view of Reformed churches and of many Baptists and other evangelicals, sometimes expressed as “eternal security” or “once saved, always saved,” though the first phrase is better because it stresses that true believers do persevere.

The case for perseverance rests on the promises of God. Jesus says his sheep “will never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand.” Paul says that those God predestined, he called; those he called, he justified; and those he justified, he glorified (Romans 8:30), with no loss along the chain. He is “sure that neither death nor life, nor angels nor rulers… will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord.” Philippians 1:6 promises that he who began a good work will bring it to completion. Jude 24 says he is able to keep us from stumbling. Salvation depends on God’s faithfulness, not ours.

Other Christians, especially in Arminian and Wesleyan traditions, hold that a true believer can, through persistent unbelief and rejection of Christ, fall from grace. They point to warning passages such as Hebrews 6:4-6, 10:26-31, and 2 Peter 2:20-22, and to Jesus’ words in John 15:1-6 about branches that do not abide. Many in this tradition affirm that believers have a strong security in Christ and that falling away is not a casual matter, but rather a deliberate abandonment of faith. Both sides take the warnings seriously. The Reformed answer is that the warnings are real means God uses to keep his people persevering: they are warnings to those who profess faith but may not have it, and they are God’s way of causing true believers to hold fast. Perseverance is something believers do, empowered by God.

Assurance is the confidence that I am a child of God. John says this is the purpose of his letter (1 John 5:13). Assurance rests on three supports. First, the promises of God in Scripture: whoever believes in him has eternal life. Second, the inward witness of the Holy Spirit, who testifies with our spirit that we are children of God (Romans 8:16). Third, the fruit in our lives: growing love, obedience, and hatred of sin. A person may be truly saved but lack assurance for a time, because of sin, depression, or weak understanding. Assurance can grow, and it is a gift to pray for.

How should we hold the doctrine? With humility and care. The warnings keep us from presumption, and the promises keep us from despair. A believer who struggles with doubt should look away from his own performance to Christ, who holds him. A person who is

careless should hear the warnings. Our confidence is not in our grip on Christ, but in his grip on us.

STEP 4

Interpretation

In John 10, Jesus describes his sheep: they hear his voice, he knows them, and they follow him. Note that the description includes following, which is a mark of true sheep. He gives them eternal life, and they will never perish. The security is double: they are in his hand and in the Father's hand. The ground is that "I and the Father are one": the power that holds us is the unlimited power of God.

Romans 8 builds an argument from God's love. If God gave his own Son for us, will he not give us all things? Who will bring a charge against God's elect? God is the one who justifies. Who is to condemn? Christ Jesus is the one who died, who was raised, who is at the right hand of God, who intercedes for us. Then the great list of possible threats: tribulation, distress, persecution, famine, nakedness, danger, sword; death, life, angels, rulers, things present, things to come, powers, height, depth, anything else in all creation. None can separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord. This is a promise for those in Christ and rests on what Christ has done.

First John 5 ties assurance to the possession of the Son. "And this is the testimony, that God gave us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. Whoever has the Son has life; whoever does not have the Son of God does not have life." The question is whether we have the Son. If we believe in his name, we have life, and God wants us to know it.

STEP 5

Connection

Philippians 1:6 and Jude 24-25 promise God's keeping. 1 Peter 1:3-5 says we are guarded by God's power through faith. Ephesians 1:13-14 says we are sealed with the Spirit. Romans 8:28-30 gives the golden chain. John 6:37-40 and 17:11-12 speak of Jesus keeping those the Father gave him. Hebrews 3:12-14, 6:4-12, and 10:26-39 are warnings. John 15:1-8 speaks of abiding. Colossians 1:21-23 calls for continuing in the faith. 2 Peter 1:10 urges making our calling and election sure. Romans 8:16 speaks of the Spirit's witness. 2 Corinthians 13:5 urges self-examination.

STEP 6

Application

If you doubt your salvation, take your eyes off yourself and look at Christ. Read John 10:27-30 slowly and rest.

If you have grown careless, hear the warnings kindly and ask whether you are abiding in Christ daily.

Share 1 John 5:13 with a struggling friend and pray that they would know they have eternal life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus, the Good Shepherd, for keeping you.

Thank him that nothing can separate you from his love.

Ask him to strengthen your assurance.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 123

"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."

1 JOHN 1:9

DAY 861 · WEEK 123

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 John 1:9 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."

1 JOHN 1:9

REST

Meditation

This verse is a gift for anyone who has failed. The condition is simple: confess. To confess means to say the same thing about our sin that God says, not minimizing, excusing, or blaming. We do not have to clean ourselves up first.

The promise is two-sided. God is faithful: he keeps his covenant promises. And he is just: the penalty has been paid by Christ, so God does not forgive by ignoring justice but by satisfying it. Therefore the forgiveness is certain.

The result has two parts: forgiveness of our sins (the guilt is removed) and cleansing from unrighteousness (the stain and power of sin are dealt with). We are not left in the pit.

When shame tells you to hide, say this verse to God, and then name the specific sin. Accept his forgiveness, and walk in the light.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read Psalms 118 and 31, all of 1 John, and a pause on perseverance. Psalm 118 told us to give thanks to the LORD, whose steadfast love endures forever, and to take refuge in him rather than in man. Psalm 31 gave the prayer of committing our spirit into God's hand. First John 1 and 2 taught us that God is light, that confession brings forgiveness, that Christ is our advocate and propitiation, and that we must not love the world. First John 3 marveled at the love of the Father who calls us his children, and defined love as laying down our lives in deed and truth. First John 4 and 5 taught us to test the spirits, that God is love, that perfect love casts out fear, and that we can know that we have eternal life. Day 860 was a pause on perseverance and assurance: God keeps his people, and he wants us to know it.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

John gives several tests of genuine faith: believing that Jesus came in the flesh, obeying God's commands, and loving one another. Which of these tests encourages you most, and which do you want to grow in?

John says Jesus Christ the righteous is our advocate with the Father and the propitiation for our sins. How does knowing that Christ pleads for you change the way you respond when you sin?

John writes that he wants you to know you have eternal life. What gives you confidence about your salvation, and what makes you doubt? What promise of Scripture can you hold on to this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess your sins to God, naming them without excuse.

Thank him that he is faithful and just to forgive and cleanse.

Rest in his forgiveness.

DAY 862 · WEEK 124

2 John 1:1-13

Truth and love; the deceivers

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 John, a single chapter. It is the shortest book in the Bible by Greek word count and takes about two minutes to read. Notice how truth and love are joined, and how hospitality has limits when false teaching is at stake.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Second John is a personal letter from "the elder" (the apostle John, in his old age) to "the elect lady and her children," either a local congregation or a Christian woman and her family. The occasion was the same as in 1 John: itinerant teachers who denied that Jesus had come in the flesh were traveling from church to church. In the ancient world, traveling teachers depended on hospitality, and a believer's home could become a base for false teaching. John writes to praise faithfulness and to give a warning.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The elect lady and her children, whom I love in truth" (v. 1).
2. "I rejoiced greatly to find some of your children walking in the truth" (v. 4).
3. "And this is love, that we walk according to his commandments" (v. 6).
4. "For many deceivers have gone out into the world, those who do not confess the coming of Jesus Christ in the flesh" (v. 7).
5. "Watch yourselves, so that you may not lose what we have worked for, but may win a full reward" (v. 8).
6. "Whoever abides in the teaching has both the Father and the Son" (v. 9).
7. "Do not receive him into your house or give him any greeting" (v. 10).

8 “So that our joy may be complete” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John greets the church with love “in truth” and with the grace of “truth and love.” The words “truth” and “love” occur together throughout the letter, and both are essential. Truth without love is hard, and love without truth is sentimental. John says that the truth “abides in us and will be with us forever.” He rejoices that some of the children are walking in the truth, just as the Father commanded.

His request is the old commandment: “that we love one another. And this is love, that we walk according to his commandments.” Love is not just a feeling; it is obedience. This is the same message as in 1 John 5:3.

Then the warning: “For many deceivers have gone out into the world, those who do not confess the coming of Jesus Christ in the flesh. Such a one is the deceiver and the antichrist.” The false teachers were denying the incarnation. John tells the readers to watch themselves, so as not to lose the fruit of their labors but to receive a full reward. He draws the line sharply: “Everyone who goes on ahead and does not abide in the teaching of Christ, does not have God. Whoever abides in the teaching has both the Father and the Son.” Those who “go on ahead” claim to advance beyond the apostles’ teaching, but in fact they leave Christ behind.

The practical instruction is: “If anyone comes to you and does not bring this teaching, do not receive him into your house or give him any greeting, for whoever greets him takes part in his wicked works.” How do we apply this? It does not forbid showing kindness to unbelievers or neighbors, and it does not tell us to be rude to those who disagree on secondary matters. It concerns teachers who deny the core of the gospel, particularly the person and work of Christ, and who come as representatives of Christian faith. To welcome and fund such a teacher would be to support his work. Each situation calls for wisdom. We should hold firmly to the truth, and we should treat the people we disagree with with the patience Christ showed.

The letter ends as it began, with warm personal greetings: John hopes to visit and speak face to face, “so that our joy may be complete.” The children of your elect sister greet you. Nothing replaces the presence of Christians together.

STEP 5

Connection

1 John 2:18-27 and 4:1-6 give the same warning. 1 John 5:3 ties love to obedience. John 14:15 and 15:10 are Jesus' words on keeping his commandments. Galatians 1:6-9 pronounces a curse on a different gospel. Titus 3:10-11 instructs us to avoid a divisive person after warnings. Romans 16:17-18 also tells us to watch out for those who cause divisions. Romans 12:13 and Hebrews 13:2 commend hospitality. Matthew 5:43-48 teaches love for enemies. Ephesians 4:15 speaks of speaking the truth in love.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize verse 6: love is walking according to God's commandments.

Ask whether you tend to emphasize truth or love, and which you may be neglecting. Take one step to bring them together.

Test what you hear and read about Jesus by the apostolic teaching. If something denies Christ's deity or humanity, be cautious.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for truth and love in Jesus.
- Ask him to help you walk in the truth and love by obeying.
- Ask him to keep you from deceivers.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 124

"Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades."

REVELATION 1:17-18

DAY 863 · WEEK 124

3 John 1:1-14

Hospitality; Gaius and Diotrephes

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 3 John, a single chapter. It is a private letter to a friend named Gaius, with a contrast between two men in the church: Gaius, who welcomed missionaries, and Diotrephes, who refused them. Notice how generosity and pride show themselves in practice.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Third John is the companion to 2 John. In 2 John, John warns against receiving false teachers. In 3 John, he commends receiving true ones. Traveling missionaries went out "for the sake of the name," relying on the hospitality of local believers rather than taking support from pagans. Gaius had welcomed them, and a leader named Diotrephes had not. The letter gives a window into the ordinary life of a first-century church with its generosity, ambition, and conflict.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Beloved, I pray that all may go well with you and that you may be in good health, as it goes well with your soul" (v. 2).
2. "I have no greater joy than to hear that my children are walking in the truth" (v. 4).
3. "Beloved, it is a faithful thing you do in all your efforts for these brothers, strangers as they are" (v. 5).
4. "For they have gone out for the sake of the name, accepting nothing from the Gentiles" (v. 7).
5. "Therefore we ought to support people like these, that we may be fellow workers for the truth" (v. 8).

6. “Diotrephes, who likes to put himself first” (v. 9).
7. “Beloved, do not imitate evil but imitate good” (v. 11).
8. “Demetrius has received a good testimony from everyone” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John writes to “the beloved Gaius, whom I love in truth.” His first words are a prayer for health: “I pray that all may go well with you and that you may be in good health, as it goes well with your soul.” It is a common greeting that implies that Gaius’s soul was doing well. It is not a promise that all believers will be healthy and wealthy but a loving wish for a friend. John rejoices when brothers testify to Gaius’s truth. “I have no greater joy than to hear that my children are walking in the truth.” For a spiritual father, there is no greater joy.

Gaius is praised for his hospitality: “it is a faithful thing you do in all your efforts for these brothers, strangers as they are.” They have testified to his love before the church. John urges him to send them on their journey “in a manner worthy of God.” Why? “For they have gone out for the sake of the name, accepting nothing from the Gentiles. Therefore we ought to support people like these, that we may be fellow workers for the truth.” When we support missionaries, teachers, and church planters, we share in their work. This is a strong argument for generosity in giving and hospitality.

By contrast, Diotrephes “likes to put himself first.” He does not acknowledge John’s authority. He is “talking wicked nonsense against us,” will not welcome the brothers, and even stops those who want to, putting them out of the church. We should not be surprised that even the early church had its power struggles. Pride is the opposite of the servant spirit of Christ. John plans to deal with him personally when he comes.

John then gives a principle: “Beloved, do not imitate evil but imitate good. Whoever does good is from God; whoever does evil has not seen God.” Our conduct reveals our relationship with God. Demetrius, probably the one who carried the letter, is commended as a model. He has a good testimony from everyone and from the truth itself.

The letter closes with the hope of seeing Gaius face to face: “Peace be to you. The friends greet you. Greet the friends, each by name.” Christian friendship is personal, valuing each by name. This tiny letter reminds us that the work of the gospel depends on ordinary acts of generosity as well as on great teachers.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 12:13, 1 Peter 4:9, and Hebrews 13:2 command hospitality. Matthew 10:9-14 describes how Jesus sent out his disciples to rely on hospitality. Philippians 4:14-18 commends partnership in giving. Titus 3:13 also speaks of sending teachers on their way. Mark 9:33-35 and 10:42-45 teach that greatness is service. 1 Peter 5:3 warns elders against domineering. Matthew 23:5-12 warns against love of honor. Luke 22:24-27 shows the disciples' own ambition. Philippians 2:3-4 calls us to humility.

STEP 6

Application

Is there a missionary, church planter, or a visiting speaker you could support with prayer, money, or hospitality? Do it this week.

Ask whether you ever "like to put yourself first" in your family, church, or workplace. Confess it and take a lower seat.

Write a note to someone who has been a Gaius to you, and thank them by name.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for friends who walk in the truth.

Ask him to make you generous to those who serve him.

Ask him to keep you from loving to be first.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 124

"Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades."

REVELATION 1:17-18

DAY 864 · WEEK 124

Jude 1:1-25

Contend for the faith once delivered

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 25 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jude, a single chapter. Jude writes with urgency about false teachers who have crept into the church, and ends with one of the most beautiful doxologies in the Bible. Notice the examples from history and the practical instructions in verses 20 to 23.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jude, the brother of James and therefore a brother of Jesus (though he calls himself a servant), intended to write about "our common salvation" but found it necessary instead to write a call to defend the faith. People had slipped into the churches who denied Christ's lordship and turned grace into an excuse for immorality. Jude's letter is closely parallel to 2 Peter 2. It uses examples from the Old Testament and from Jewish writings of the period.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Contend for the faith that was once for all delivered to the saints" (v. 3).
2. "Pervert the grace of our God into sensuality" (v. 4).
3. "He did not presume to pronounce a blasphemous judgment" (v. 9).
4. "Building yourselves up in your most holy faith; praying in the Holy Spirit" (v. 20).
5. "Keep yourselves in the love of God, waiting for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ that leads to eternal life" (v. 21).
6. "And have mercy on those who doubt" (v. 22).
7. "Save others by snatching them out of the fire" (v. 23).
8. "Now to him who is able to keep you from stumbling and to present you blameless before the presence of his glory with great joy" (v. 24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jude introduces himself and greets his readers as "those who are called, beloved in God the Father and kept for Jesus Christ." Called, loved, kept: three words that summarize the Christian's security. Then the appeal: "Contend for the faith that was once for all delivered to the saints." The faith is a body of truth, entrusted to the apostles, complete and unchanging. We do not invent it or improve on it, but we guard and defend it. "Contend" is a strong word, like an athlete struggling for a prize, though Paul says the servant of the Lord must not be quarrelsome (2 Timothy 2:24). The way to contend is with truth, courage, and compassion.

The danger: "certain people have crept in unnoticed who long ago were designated for this condemnation, ungodly people, who pervert the grace of our God into sensuality and deny our only Master and Lord, Jesus Christ." Their error is two-fold: moral (grace as license) and doctrinal (denying Christ's lordship). Jude gives three examples of judgment: Israel, who was saved out of Egypt but destroyed when they did not believe; the angels who left their proper place; and Sodom and Gomorrah. Great privilege does not protect those who persist in unbelief.

The false teachers "reject authority and blaspheme the glorious ones." Jude contrasts them with the archangel Michael, who, even in a dispute with the devil, "did not presume to pronounce a blasphemous judgment, but said, The Lord rebuke you." Jude refers to a tradition about Michael and Moses' body, probably from a Jewish writing of the time, and to a prophecy of Enoch, which seems to come from the Book of 1 Enoch. Does that make these books Scripture? No. Paul also quoted pagan poets (Acts 17:28) without making them canonical. An inspired author may cite a true statement from a non-inspired source. This is why the canon (see Day 851) is important.

Jude's descriptions of the false teachers are some of the most vivid in the Bible: "hidden reefs" at the love feasts, "waterless clouds, swept along by winds," "fruitless trees in autumn, twice dead, uprooted," "wild waves of the sea, casting up the foam of their own shame," "wandering stars for whom the gloom of utter darkness has been reserved forever." Their end is judgment, as Enoch prophesied. They are grumblers, malcontents, following their own sinful desires, loud-mouthed boasters, showing favoritism for gain.

Then Jude turns to the readers: "But you, beloved, remember the predictions of the apostles of our Lord Jesus Christ." Scoffers will come. Our response is a fourfold program: "building yourselves up in your most holy faith; praying in the Holy Spirit, keep yourselves in the love of God, waiting for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ that leads to eternal life." Notice the Trinity: Spirit, God, Lord Jesus. Faith, prayer, love, and hope together keep us in God's love. And then ministry to others: "And have mercy on those who doubt; save others by snatching

them out of the fire; to others show mercy with fear, hating even the garment stained by the flesh." Three types of people receive three types of care: gentleness for the doubting, urgency for the endangered, and cautious compassion for those entangled in sin.

The letter ends with a doxology that has been read at countless services: "Now to him who is able to keep you from stumbling and to present you blameless before the presence of his glory with great joy, to the only God, our Savior, through Jesus Christ our Lord, be glory, majesty, dominion, and authority, before all time and now and forever. Amen." We contend for the faith, but ultimately it is God who keeps us. And he will present us blameless, with great joy.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Peter 2 is a close parallel. Numbers 14 and 26:64-65 record the wilderness generation. Genesis 6:1-4 and 19:1-29 relate to the angels and Sodom. Zechariah 3:2 contains the words "The Lord rebuke you." Genesis 5:18-24 mentions Enoch. Numbers 16 and 22-24 tell of Korah and Balaam. Genesis 4:3-8 tells of Cain. 1 Timothy 6:20 and 2 Timothy 1:13-14 call us to guard the deposit. Acts 20:28-31 warns of wolves. Romans 16:25-27 is another great doxology. Philippians 1:6 and 1 Thessalonians 5:23-24 offer similar assurance.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize verse 24, and say it at the end of the day as a prayer of trust.

Choose one of the four disciplines in verses 20 and 21 (faith, prayer, love, hope) and strengthen it this week.

Think of a person who doubts. Reach out to them with patience and mercy.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are called, loved, and kept.

Ask him to help you contend for the faith with truth and love.

Ask him to keep you in his love and show mercy to the doubting.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 124

"Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades."

REVELATION 1:17-18

DAY 865 · WEEK 124

Review and Reflection

Unit 24 review, Faith Lived Out, General Epistles

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "We love because he first loved us."
>
> 1 JOHN 4:19

REST

Meditation

This short verse is the heart of the General Epistles. James told us that faith without works is dead, Peter told us to love one another earnestly, John told us that God is love, and Jude told us to keep ourselves in the love of God. Where does that love begin? Not in us. "We love because he first loved us."

The love of God came first, in the cross: "In this is love, not that we have loved God but that he loved us and sent his Son to be the propitiation for our sins." Our love for God and for each other is the echo of his. We are not trying to earn love; we are responding to a love already given.

This is freeing. On days when we feel unloving, we do not manufacture love by willpower. We look again at the love that came first, and let it fill us and overflow. Say this verse slowly, and thank him for loving you first.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

This unit took us through the General Epistles, which ask what genuine faith looks like in real life. James taught that faith is tested by trials and shown by works: we are to be doers of the word, tame the tongue by God's grace, show no partiality, and pray with patience. Psalms 12, 15, and 24 deepened this with the purity of the LORD's words, the character of those who dwell with God, and the King of glory who alone has clean hands and a pure heart. We paused to consider saving faith: knowing, agreeing, trusting, and how faith alone is never alone. First Peter gave us a living hope, our identity as a chosen race, royal priesthood, and

holy nation, the example of Christ's suffering, and the call to cast our anxieties on God while resisting the roaring lion. Second Peter reminded us that God has given us everything for life and godliness, that Scripture is breathed out by the Spirit, and that the Lord's delay is patience. We paused on the canon: why we have sixty-six books. Psalms 34, 118, and 31 invited us to taste and see, to give thanks for steadfast love, and to commit our spirit to God's hand. First John gave tests of genuine faith: walking in the light, confessing sin, loving the brothers, believing in the incarnate Son, and knowing that we have eternal life. We paused on perseverance and assurance. Second John and Third John showed truth and love in hospitality, and Jude called us to contend for the faith once delivered and trust the God who is able to keep us from stumbling.

REFLECT

Review Questions

How does James reconcile "faith without works is dead" with justification by faith alone?

In your own words, explain how Paul and James fit together, and give one example of faith showing itself in works.

What does Peter mean by "a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation"?

Write what these titles tell you about who you are as a Christian, and how they shape how you live as an exile.

What are the tests of genuine faith in 1 John?

List the tests John gives, and choose one you want to grow in this month.

What does Jude mean when he says to "contend for the faith"?

Describe what it looks like to contend for the faith with both truth and mercy, using verses 20 to 23.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for loving you first.

Thank him for what the General Epistles have taught you about living the faith.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 25 · DAYS 866-900

The New Covenant Consummated: Revelation

Revelation 1-22

The Lamb wins. All God's covenantal promises find their Yes in Christ. New creation.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people."

REVELATION 21:3-4

Psalms 1, 19, and 29 at the opening. Throne psalms (2, 46, 93, 97) before the bowls. Psalms 72:18-19 and 150 at the close.

UNIT 25

In this unit

WEEK 124

866	Revelation 1:1-20	*Reading*
867	Revelation 2:1-29	*Reading*
868	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 125

869	Revelation 3:1-22	*Reading*
870	Psalm 1	*Psalm*
871	Psalm 19	*Psalm*
872	Psalm 29	*Psalm*
873	Revelation 4:1-5:14	*Reading*
874	Revelation 6:1-17	*Reading*
875	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 126

876	Revelation 7:1-8:13	*Reading*
877	Revelation 9:1-11:19	*Reading*
878	Psalm 141	*Psalm*
879	Psalm 150	*Psalm*
880	Psalm 148	*Psalm*
881	Revelation 12:1-13:18	*Reading*
882	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 127

883	Revelation 14:1-15:8	*Reading*
884	Psalm 2	*Psalm*
885	Psalm 46	*Psalm*
886	Psalm 93	*Psalm*
887	Psalm 97	*Psalm*

888	Revelation 16:1-21	*Reading*
889	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 128

890	Revelation 17:1-18:24	*Reading*
891	Revelation 19:1-20:15	*Reading*
892	Revelation 20:11-15; Matthew 25:31-46; 2 Corinthians 5:10	*Doctrine*
893	Revelation 21:1-22:5	*Reading*
894	Revelation 21:1-22:5; Isaiah 65:17-25; 2 Peter 3:10-13	*Doctrine*
895	Revelation 22:6-21	*Reading*
896	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 129

897	Psalm 72:18-19	*Psalm*
898	Psalm 150	*Psalm*
899	Review and Reflection	*Review*
900	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 866 · WEEK 124

Revelation 1:1-20

The vision of Christ, the risen Lord among his churches

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 1:1-20 in one sitting. This is the opening of the last book of the Bible. Notice how often the language echoes the Old Testament, and how the book begins and ends with Jesus Christ, not with a timetable of events.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The apostle John, now an old man, was exiled on the island of Patmos in the Aegean Sea around AD 95, during the reign of the emperor Domitian, when emperor worship was pressing on the churches of Asia Minor. Revelation is a letter to seven real churches, a prophecy, and an apocalypse: a kind of writing that uses symbols and visions to unveil what is true behind the surface of history. It is full of images drawn from Daniel, Ezekiel, Isaiah, Zechariah, Exodus, and the Psalms, and nearly every verse echoes the Old Testament. It is not a puzzle to decode but a vision to be seen and a book to be heard. Its message to suffering believers is: Jesus reigns, and the Lamb wins.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Blessed is the one who reads aloud the words of this prophecy, and blessed are those who hear, and who keep what is written in it, for the time is near” (v. 3).
2. “To him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by his blood” (v. 5).
3. “Behold, he is coming with the clouds, and every eye will see him” (v. 7).
4. “I am the Alpha and the Omega, says the Lord God, who is and who was and who is to come, the Almighty” (v. 8).
5. “I, John, your brother and partner in the tribulation and the kingdom and the patient endurance that are in Jesus” (v. 9).

6. “From his mouth came a sharp two-edged sword, and his face was like the sun shining in full strength” (v. 16).
7. “I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades” (v. 18).
8. “The seven stars are the angels of the seven churches, and the seven lampstands are the seven churches” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book begins, “The revelation of Jesus Christ.” The Greek word is apokalypsis, an unveiling. It is a revelation from Jesus and about Jesus. And it begins with a blessing, the first of seven in the book: “Blessed is the one who reads aloud the words of this prophecy, and blessed are those who hear, and who keep what is written in it.” It was meant to be read aloud in the churches and obeyed. “The time is near” means that its message presses on every generation.

The greeting is to the seven churches in Asia, from the triune God: from him “who is and who was and who is to come” (the Father), from the “seven spirits who are before his throne” (the Holy Spirit in his fullness), and from Jesus Christ, “the faithful witness, the firstborn of the dead, and the ruler of kings on earth.” Notice the three titles: he witnessed faithfully, he rose first, and he rules even over the emperor. Then a burst of praise: “To him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by his blood and made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father, to him be glory and dominion forever and ever. Amen.” This borrows the language of Exodus 19:6 and applies it to the church, as Peter does. Then a promise combining Daniel 7:13 and Zechariah 12:10: “Behold, he is coming with the clouds, and every eye will see him, even those who pierced him, and all tribes of the earth will wail on account of him.” And God himself speaks: “I am the Alpha and the Omega,” the first and last letters of the Greek alphabet, the beginning and the end.

John describes himself as a “brother and partner in the tribulation and the kingdom and the patient endurance that are in Jesus.” Those three are always together for Christians: suffering, kingdom, and endurance. He was on Patmos “on account of the word of God and the testimony of Jesus.” On the Lord’s day (Sunday, the day of Christ’s resurrection) he was “in the Spirit” and heard a loud voice like a trumpet telling him to write what he sees to the seven churches.

He turns and sees seven golden lampstands, and in the midst “one like a son of man” (Daniel 7:13). His description is overwhelming: a long robe and golden sash, hair white like wool, eyes like a flame of fire, feet like burnished bronze, voice like the roar of many waters, in his right hand seven stars, from his mouth a sharp two-edged sword, and his face like the sun in

full strength. Almost every feature recalls the Old Testament's descriptions of God and the Ancient of Days. Jesus is portrayed as divine, glorious, and terrifying. John falls at his feet as though dead. But Jesus lays his right hand on him and says, "Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades." The same one who is glorious is the one who died. His keys mean that death and the grave answer to him. No one needs to fear them.

He tells John to write what he has seen, what is now, and what will take place after this. The seven stars and lampstands are explained: the stars are the angels (or messengers) of the churches, and the lampstands are the churches themselves. Jesus walks among his churches. He knows them, holds them, and judges them. Interpreters have understood Revelation in different ways: as largely about events in the first century (preterist), as the sweep of church history (historicist), as symbols of the spiritual struggle across all ages (idealist), or as largely about events at the end of history (futurist). Many thoughtful readers combine elements of these. In every approach, the center is clear: Christ is Lord, and his church is held in his hand.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 7:9-14 and 10:5-6 stand behind the vision of the Son of Man. Exodus 19:5-6 is the source of "a kingdom, priests." Zechariah 12:10 and Matthew 24:30 relate to verse 7. Isaiah 41:4 and 44:6 are behind the Alpha and Omega and the first and last. Ezekiel 1 and Isaiah 6 show similar overwhelming visions. John 1:1-18 and Philippians 2:9-11 speak of Christ's glory. Hebrews 2:14-15 speaks of the defeat of death. Acts 4:12 and Romans 14:9 speak of Christ's lordship. 1 Peter 2:9 says believers are a royal priesthood. Zechariah 4 describes the lampstand.

STEP 6

Application

Read the book aloud today, as the blessing in verse 3 invites. Even reading the first chapter aloud will help you hear it as its first audience did.

Picture the risen Christ walking among your church. What would he commend, and what would he correct?

When you fear death or what is ahead, say verse 18 to yourself: the living one holds the keys.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Worship Jesus, the faithful witness and ruler of kings.

Thank him for loving you and freeing you from your sins.

Ask him to keep you from fear, and listen to him say, “Fear not.”

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 124

“Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades.”

REVELATION 1:17-18

DAY 867 · WEEK 124

Revelation 2:1-29

Letters to Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum, Thyatira

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 29 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 2:1-29. Jesus speaks to four of the seven churches: Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum, and Thyatira. Notice the pattern in each letter: a description of Christ, what he knows, what he commends or criticizes, a call to listen, and a promise to the one who conquers.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The seven churches were real congregations in cities of Asia Minor, arranged along a circular road. Each letter reflects its city's setting: Ephesus, a great port and the center of the cult of Artemis; Smyrna, loyal to Rome, with a hostile Jewish community; Pergamum, with temples to Zeus, Asclepius, and the emperor; Thyatira, a city of trade guilds that required participation in pagan feasts. The letters also work as a mirror for churches of every age, because the problems of love grown cold, persecution, compromise, and tolerance of false teaching never go away.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But I have this against you, that you have abandoned the love you had at first" (v. 4).
2. "Remember therefore from where you have fallen; repent, and do the works you did at first" (v. 5).
3. "To the one who conquers I will grant to eat of the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God" (v. 7).
4. "Be faithful unto death, and I will give you the crown of life" (v. 10).
5. "Therefore repent. If not, I will come to you soon and war against them with the sword of my mouth" (v. 16).

6. “A white stone, with a new name written on the stone that no one knows except the one who receives it” (v. 17).
7. “I am he who searches mind and heart” (v. 23).
8. “And I will give him the morning star” (v. 28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

To Ephesus, Jesus is the one who walks among the lampstands. He commends their works, toil, patient endurance, and refusal to tolerate evil, and their testing of false apostles. “But I have this against you, that you have abandoned the love you had at first.” They had kept the doctrine but lost the love. The remedy has three parts: “Remember therefore from where you have fallen; repent, and do the works you did at first.” If not, he will remove their lampstand. Correct doctrine without warm love is a dying church. The promise to the conqueror: “I will grant to eat of the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God,” the restoration of Eden.

To Smyrna, Jesus is “the first and the last, who died and came to life.” There is no criticism, only comfort. “I know your tribulation and your poverty (but you are rich).” They are slandered and about to suffer imprisonment. “Do not fear what you are about to suffer… Be faithful unto death, and I will give you the crown of life.” Polycarp, the bishop of Smyrna, was martyred about sixty years later, saying he had served Christ eighty-six years. The promise: the conqueror “will not be hurt by the second death.” The first death can touch the body; the second cannot touch the faithful.

To Pergamum, Jesus has “the sharp two-edged sword.” The church lives “where Satan’s throne is,” probably a reference to the center of emperor worship. They have held fast his name, even when Antipas, “my faithful witness,” was killed. But some hold the teaching of Balaam (who led Israel into idolatry and sexual immorality, Numbers 25) and the Nicolaitans. The command: “Therefore repent.” The conqueror will receive “hidden manna” and a white stone with a new name, signs of provision and of acceptance and a personal identity from Christ.

To Thyatira, Jesus is the Son of God, “whose eyes are like a flame of fire.” This is the only place in Revelation he is called Son of God. The church is growing in love, faith, service, and patience, but “you tolerate that woman Jezebel,” who calls herself a prophetess and leads his servants into sexual immorality and food offered to idols. Jesus gave her time to repent, but she refuses. He warns: “I am he who searches mind and heart, and I will give to each of you as your works deserve.” Those who have not followed her teaching are to hold fast until he comes. The conqueror receives authority over the nations, sharing Christ’s rule (Psalm 2:8-9), and “the morning star,” which is Christ himself (22:16).

Each letter ends: “He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches.” The promises to the conqueror are not for a special class of believers. In 1 John 5:4-5, everyone born of God conquers through faith in Jesus. The conqueror is the persevering believer. Christ knows what we face, and he will keep his promises.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 19 tells of the founding of the church in Ephesus. Ephesians 6:23-24 speaks of love for the Lord. Genesis 2:9 and 3:22-24 describe the tree of life. Revelation 20:6 and 21:8 speak of the second death. Numbers 22-25 and 31:16 are the story of Balaam. 1 Kings 16:31-33 and 2 Kings 9 tell of Jezebel. Psalm 2:7-9 is the background of authority over the nations. 1 Corinthians 8 and 10:14-22 discuss food offered to idols. Jeremiah 17:10 and Romans 8:27 speak of God searching hearts. 2 Peter 1:19 and Revelation 22:16 mention the morning star. 1 John 5:4-5 says every believer conquers.

STEP 6

Application

Ask if your love for Christ and for his people is what it was at first. If not, follow the three steps: remember, repent, and return.

If you face pressure or ridicule for your faith, take the words to Smyrna to heart: do not fear; be faithful.

What teaching or practice do you tolerate that Christ would not? Bring it to him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that he walks among his churches and knows your works.
- Confess where you have compromised.
- Ask him to give you endurance and faithfulness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 124

“Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades.”

REVELATION 1:17-18

DAY 868 · WEEK 124

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Revelation 1:17-18 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades."

REVELATION 1:17-18

REST

Meditation

John, the beloved disciple who once leaned on Jesus' chest at supper, falls at his feet as though dead when he sees the risen Christ in glory. Even for a friend, the glory of the Lord is overwhelming. And then Jesus lays his right hand on him and speaks the most common command in the Bible: "Fear not."

The reason is who Jesus is: the first and the last, the living one. He has always been and will always be. And his credentials are astonishing: "I died, and behold I am alive forevermore." He has gone through the one door that no one else returned from. He holds the keys of Death and Hades.

If he holds the keys, then death is not a locked door he cannot open; the grave has an owner, and he is your Savior. When fear comes today, put your hand in his right hand, the one he laid on John, and hear him say again, "Fear not."

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the book of Revelation. Chapter 1 unveiled the risen Christ: the faithful witness, the firstborn of the dead, and the ruler of kings, the Alpha and Omega, the Son of Man in glory with a sword in his mouth and the keys of Death and Hades in his hand, walking among his churches. Chapter 2 gave his letters to Ephesus (love grown cold), Smyrna (faithful in suffering), Pergamum (compromise with the world), and Thyatira (tolerating false teaching), each with a promise to the one who conquers: the tree of life, the crown of life, the hidden manna and white stone, and the morning star.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

John saw Jesus in glory and fell as though dead, yet Jesus touched him and said, “Fear not.” What fear do you most need Jesus to speak that word over right now?

Ephesus had sound doctrine but had lost its first love. Honestly, how would you describe your love for Christ and for his people right now, and what is one step toward returning to the works you did at first?

Jesus says to the conqueror at Smyrna that he will receive the crown of life. How does the promise that Christ himself died and came to life help you face suffering or fear of death?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that he is the first and the last, the living one.

Thank him that he holds the keys of death and Hades.

Rest in his hand.

DAY 869 · WEEK 125

Revelation 3:1-22

Letters to Sardis, Philadelphia, Laodicea

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 3:1-22. Jesus speaks to the last three of the seven churches: Sardis, Philadelphia, and Laodicea. Notice that two churches receive only criticism, one receives only praise, and the best-known verse in the chapter is addressed to a church, not to an individual.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Sardis was a wealthy city that had twice fallen to surprise attacks because its defenders thought the acropolis was unassailable. Philadelphia, a small and relatively weak city, was known for earthquakes and for being a gateway to the east. Laodicea was a rich banking and textile center, famous for its black wool, an eye salve, and a water supply piped in from hot springs and cold streams that arrived lukewarm. Jesus addresses each church using images drawn from its own setting.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “You have the reputation of being alive, but you are dead” (v. 1).
2. “Wake up, and strengthen what remains and is about to die” (v. 2).
3. “I have set before you an open door, which no one is able to shut” (v. 8).
4. “Because you are lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold, I will spit you out of my mouth” (v. 16).
5. “For you say, I am rich, I have prospered, and I need nothing” (v. 17).
6. “Those whom I love, I reprove and discipline, so be zealous and repent” (v. 19).

7. “Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and eat with him, and he with me” (v. 20).

8. “The one who conquers, I will grant him to sit with me on my throne, as I also conquered and sat down with my Father on his throne” (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

To Sardis, Jesus holds “the seven spirits of God and the seven stars.” He says, “I know your works. You have the reputation of being alive, but you are dead.” It is the harshest letter, with no commendation. The church looked fine from outside but was spiritually asleep, as the city had been when it fell. “Wake up, and strengthen what remains and is about to die.” They are to remember what they received and heard, keep it, and repent. If not, he will come like a thief. A few in Sardis have not soiled their garments, and “they will walk with me in white, for they are worthy.” The conqueror will be clothed in white, and Jesus “will never blot his name out of the book of life,” but will confess his name before the Father and his angels. This is a promise of security for the faithful.

To Philadelphia, Jesus is “the holy one, the true one, who has the key of David, who opens and no one will shut.” There is only praise. “I know that you have but little power, and yet you have kept my word and have not denied my name.” Christ has set before them “an open door, which no one is able to shut,” perhaps for gospel opportunity. He will make those who slander them come and bow down before their feet, and know that he has loved them. “Because you have kept my word about patient endurance, I will keep you from the hour of trial that is coming on the whole world.” Interpreters differ on whether this means being kept through trials (as in John 17:15) or removed from them (as taught in some forms of premillennialism); either way, the promise is that Christ guards the faithful. The conqueror will be made “a pillar in the temple of my God,” never to go out of it, and will have written on him the name of God, of the city of God, and Christ’s own new name.

To Laodicea, Jesus is “the Amen, the faithful and true witness, the beginning of God’s creation.” There is no commendation here either. “I know your works: you are neither cold nor hot. Would that you were either cold or hot! So, because you are lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold, I will spit you out of my mouth.” Laodicea’s water came lukewarm from afar: not refreshing like cold water or healing like hot. The church’s works were useless. Their self-image was prosperous: “I am rich, I have prospered, and I need nothing.” But Jesus says they are “wretched, pitiable, poor, blind, and naked.” Their remedy is to buy from him gold refined by fire, white garments, and eye salve, answers to the city’s banking, textile, and medical fame. “Those whom I love, I reprove and discipline, so be zealous and repent.”

Then the most famous verse: “Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and eat with him, and he with me.” This is often used as an invitation to unbelievers, but its original setting is Christ knocking on the door of his own church. He is on the outside of a congregation that thinks it needs nothing. The invitation to repent and renew fellowship, symbolized by a shared meal, applies to every church and every believer who has drifted. The final promise is the highest of all: “The one who conquers, I will grant him to sit with me on my throne, as I also conquered and sat down with my Father on his throne.” The letters end as they began, with the call to hear. Christ does not just judge his churches; he loves them and calls them back.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 24:42-44 and 1 Thessalonians 5:2-6 speak of coming like a thief. Isaiah 22:22 is the source of the key of David. Isaiah 45:14 and 49:23 are behind the bowing at their feet. Isaiah 60:14 speaks of enemies bowing. John 17:15 prays that the Father would keep believers from the evil one. Colossians 4:13-16 mentions Laodicea. Hosea 12:8 and 1 Corinthians 4:8 speak of self-satisfaction. Proverbs 3:11-12 and Hebrews 12:5-11 speak of the Lord’s discipline. Song of Solomon 5:2 has a similar knocking at the door. Luke 12:35-37 and John 14:23 speak of fellowship with Christ. Luke 22:28-30 promises a share in his throne.

STEP 6

Application

Honestly ask: if people could see your inner spiritual life, would they say you are alive? Pick one thing to strengthen that is about to die.

Open the door to Christ for an area of your life where you have been self-sufficient. Tell him you need him.

Thank Christ for the discipline you may be experiencing as a sign of his love.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask Jesus to wake you up where you are asleep.
- Thank him for the open door he has set before you.
- Ask him for the courage to open your door to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 125

“Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!”

REVELATION 5:12

DAY 870 · WEEK 125

Psalm 1

Blessed is the man, the two ways

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 1. It is the gateway to the whole book of Psalms, and its picture of a tree by streams of water returns in the last chapter of the Bible. Notice the two ways, the two destinies, and the one who delights in God's law.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 1 has no title. It stands as the introduction to the Psalter, setting out the choice that all of the other psalms assume: there are two ways to live, and they lead to two ends. It reads like a wisdom poem, in the tradition of Proverbs and Deuteronomy 30. We now return to it as we begin the last book of the Bible, where the same two ways appear for the last time, in the tree of life and in the judgment of the wicked.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed is the man who walks not in the counsel of the wicked, nor stands in the way of sinners, nor sits in the seat of scoffers" (v. 1).
2. "But his delight is in the law of the LORD, and on his law he meditates day and night" (v. 2).
3. "He is like a tree planted by streams of water that yields its fruit in its season" (v. 3).
4. "In all that he does, he prospers" (v. 3).
5. "The wicked are not so, but are like chaff that the wind drives away" (v. 4).
6. "Therefore the wicked will not stand in the judgment" (v. 5).
7. "For the LORD knows the way of the righteous" (v. 6).
8. "But the way of the wicked will perish" (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first word is “Blessed,” meaning deeply, lastingly happy. The blessed man is first described by what he avoids. Notice the progression: he walks, then stands, then sits. First he takes the counsel of the wicked, then he stands in the way of sinners, then he settles into the seat of scoffers. Sin starts as a casual step and becomes a way of life. The blessed person refuses to start down that road.

What he does instead is delight in God’s law: “on his law he meditates day and night.” The word “law” is torah, God’s instruction, and it points to the whole of God’s revealed word. Delight means that it is not merely a duty; it is a pleasure. Meditation means that he turns it over and over, as a cow chews the cud. The result is a picture of stability and fruit: “He is like a tree planted by streams of water that yields its fruit in its season, and its leaf does not wither.” The tree is planted, not wild; its roots reach the water; it does not wither in drought. “In all that he does, he prospers.” This is not a promise of worldly wealth for everyone who reads the Bible; it is a description of a life that, in God’s sight, succeeds and bears lasting fruit. Jeremiah 17:7-8 uses the same image.

By contrast, “The wicked are not so.” They are like chaff, the weightless husk the wind blows away. They have no roots, no fruit, no future. “Therefore the wicked will not stand in the judgment, nor sinners in the congregation of the righteous.” The psalm ends with the reason: “For the LORD knows the way of the righteous, but the way of the wicked will perish.” God knows, which means he watches over and cares for the way of the righteous, as in the phrase “The LORD knows those who are his.”

Reading this psalm in the light of Christ, we see that he is the truly blessed man. He alone never walked in the counsel of the wicked, and his delight was in the law of the LORD (Psalm 40:8). He is the tree whose fruit never fails. And in Revelation 22:2, the tree of life stands by the river of the water of life, bearing twelve kinds of fruit, with leaves for the healing of the nations. Those who are in Christ are planted by the streams of water, and one day will eat of that tree. The two ways of Psalm 1 are the two ways of the whole Bible, and the last chapters of Revelation show where each ends.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 17:7-8 uses the image of a tree by water. Joshua 1:8 commands meditating on the law day and night. Psalm 119 is an extended meditation on the law. Deuteronomy 30:15-20 sets before Israel life and death. Proverbs 4:14-19 describes two paths. Matthew 7:13-14

speaks of the two ways. Psalm 40:6-8 and Hebrews 10:5-9 show Christ delighting to do God's will. John 15:1-8 speaks of abiding and bearing fruit. Genesis 2:9 and Revelation 2:7, 22:2 mention the tree of life. Matthew 3:12 speaks of chaff.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what counsel you have been listening to, and where you may be starting to "walk, stand, or sit" in a place you should not.

Choose a short passage and meditate on it throughout the day. Return to it when you have a spare moment.

Thank Christ that he is the blessed man in your place, and that his roots reach to the stream of life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you want to be blessed as his word describes.
- Ask him to keep you from the counsel of the wicked.
- Ask him to root you in his word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 125

"Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!"

REVELATION 5:12

DAY 871 · WEEK 125

Psalm 19

The heavens declare; the law revives the soul

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 19. Notice the three movements: the voice of creation (vv. 1-6), the perfection of God's word (vv. 7-11), and the prayer of a servant who asks to be cleansed and made acceptable (vv. 12-14).

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 19 is a psalm of David. C. S. Lewis called it one of the greatest poems in the Psalter. It joins two ways in which God speaks: through the heavens (general revelation) and through his word (special revelation). We read the first part earlier in connection with Paul's use of it in Romans 10. Today we read it as a whole, as we move into Revelation, where the whole creation and God's written word are central.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork" (v. 1).
2. "Day to day pours out speech, and night to night reveals knowledge" (v. 2).
3. "The law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul" (v. 7).
4. "The precepts of the LORD are right, rejoicing the heart" (v. 8).
5. "More to be desired are they than gold, even much fine gold; sweeter also than honey and drippings of the honeycomb" (v. 10).
6. "Moreover, by them is your servant warned; in keeping them there is great reward" (v. 11).
7. "Who can discern his errors? Declare me innocent from hidden faults" (v. 12).

8 “Let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable in your sight, O LORD, my rock and my redeemer” (v. 14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with the sky: “The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork.” The created order is a continual testimony. “Day to day pours out speech, and night to night reveals knowledge. There is no speech, nor are there words, whose voice is not heard.” Creation speaks without words and in every language, and “their voice goes out through all the earth.” In the heavens, God has set a tent for the sun, which rises like a bridegroom and runs its course like a strong man with joy. “There is nothing hidden from its heat.” This general revelation shows the power and glory of the Creator but does not tell us how to be saved. For that we need his word.

The second part turns to the word, with six names for it (law, testimony, precepts, commandment, fear, rules) and six effects. “The law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul; the testimony of the LORD is sure, making wise the simple; the precepts of the LORD are right, rejoicing the heart; the commandment of the LORD is pure, enlightening the eyes; the fear of the LORD is clean, enduring forever; the rules of the LORD are true, and righteous altogether.” This is how the Bible works: it restores the weary, makes the simple wise, brings joy, gives light, endures forever, and proves true. “More to be desired are they than gold, even much fine gold; sweeter also than honey and drippings of the honeycomb.” The psalmist treasures the word more than wealth and enjoys it more than sweets.

The third part is personal. Having seen the glory of God in creation and in his word, the psalmist sees himself. “Who can discern his errors? Declare me innocent from hidden faults. Keep back your servant also from presumptuous sins; let them not have dominion over me! Then I shall be blameless, and innocent of great transgression.” The word is a mirror that shows sins we cannot see by ourselves. He asks for cleansing from the hidden and the willful. And he ends with a prayer that has been prayed by preachers for centuries: “Let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable in your sight, O LORD, my rock and my redeemer.”

The movement from the stars to the Scripture to the sinner is the movement of faith. We look up and see glory, we look into God’s word and see grace, and we look inward and see our need. In Revelation, the creation praises its Creator (4:11; 5:13), the book is opened, and the redeemer is the Lamb. The one who is our rock is also our redeemer.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 1:18-20 and 10:18 draw on creation's testimony. Psalm 8, 33, and 104 also praise God in creation. Psalm 119:97-105 and Deuteronomy 4:6-8 praise the law. 2 Timothy 3:15-17 describes the use of Scripture. Hebrews 4:12 describes the word as living. Psalm 90:8 and 139:23-24 speak of hidden sin. Psalm 51:1-12 asks for cleansing. John 8:12 and 1 John 1:5 link light to God. Revelation 4:11 and 5:13 have creation praising God. Isaiah 41:14 and 44:6 call God redeemer.

STEP 6

Application

Step outside today and look at the sky. Let it speak. Tell God what it says to you about him.

Read one of the descriptions of the law (vv. 7-9) and pray for the effect you most need: reviving, wisdom, joy, or light.

Pray verse 14 before you speak or write something important.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for speaking through the heavens and through his word.
- Ask him to cleanse you from hidden faults.
- Pray Psalm 19:14 as your own.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 125

"Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!"

REVELATION 5:12

DAY 872 · WEEK 125

Psalm 29

The voice of the LORD, Revelation's thunders

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 29. The psalm is built around the phrase "the voice of the LORD," repeated seven times. Read it aloud and listen for the sound of a storm moving across the land.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 29 is a psalm of David describing a thunderstorm that sweeps in from the Mediterranean, crosses the mountains of Lebanon, and moves down to the wilderness of Kadesh in the south. It was probably used in worship at the temple. Canaanite religion said that Baal, the storm god, ruled the thunder. This psalm declares that the thunder is the voice of the LORD, and only he is the God of glory. It stands next to Revelation's thunders and the heavenly worship of chapters 4 and 5.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Ascribe to the LORD, O heavenly beings, ascribe to the LORD glory and strength" (v. 1).
2. "Worship the LORD in the splendor of holiness" (v. 2).
3. "The voice of the LORD is over the waters; the God of glory thunders" (v. 3).
4. "The voice of the LORD is powerful; the voice of the LORD is full of majesty" (v. 4).
5. "The voice of the LORD breaks the cedars" (v. 5).
6. "In his temple all cry, Glory!" (v. 9).
7. "The LORD sits enthroned over the flood; the LORD sits enthroned as king forever" (v. 10).
8. "May the LORD give strength to his people! May the LORD bless his people with peace!" (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins in heaven: “Ascribe to the LORD, O heavenly beings, ascribe to the LORD glory and strength. Ascribe to the LORD the glory due his name; worship the LORD in the splendor of holiness.” Even the angels are called to give God the glory that belongs to him. The word “ascribe” means to give him what is already his.

Then seven times we hear the voice of the LORD. His voice is “over the waters,” that is, over the sea and the storm clouds. It “is powerful” and “full of majesty.” It “breaks the cedars,” the greatest trees of the ancient world. It makes Lebanon and Sirion (Mount Hermon) “skip like a calf, and Sirion like a young wild ox.” The mountains jump at his voice. It “flashes forth flames of fire,” meaning lightning, and it “shakes the wilderness.” The voice “makes the deer give birth and strips the forests bare.” Everything in creation trembles. And in the middle of the storm, “in his temple all cry, Glory!” Only in the temple do people understand what the thunder means: God is speaking.

The first half is about the voice of the LORD in nature, and the last is about the LORD enthroned: “The LORD sits enthroned over the flood; the LORD sits enthroned as king forever.” The flood recalls Noah, and the chaos waters of creation. God is not threatened by floods; he sits above them. He is king forever.

The last verse is the application: “May the LORD give strength to his people! May the LORD bless his people with peace!” The God whose voice shakes the mountains is the God who gives his people strength and peace. Power is not a threat to those who belong to him; it is their shelter.

In Revelation, the same imagery is used. From the throne come “flashes of lightning, and rumblings and peals of thunder” (4:5). Seven thunders speak in 10:3-4. In 19:6, the great multitude hears “the sound of many waters and like the sound of mighty peals of thunder, crying out, Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns.” In Christ, the voice of God has come in its fullest form. Hebrews 12:26 says that his voice shook the earth then, and will shake not only the earth but also the heavens.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 19:16-19 and 20:18-19 describe the voice of God at Sinai. Job 37:2-5 and 38:1 describe God’s thunder. Psalm 18:13-15 and 77:18 also describe thunder. 1 Chronicles 16:28-29 echoes the call to ascribe glory. Genesis 6-9 is the flood. Psalm 93:3-4 and 104:7 also speak of the waters. Revelation 4:5, 8:5, 10:3-4, and 19:6 mention thunder. Hebrews 12:25-28 says God’s voice shakes heaven and earth. John 12:28-29 records a voice from heaven that some took for thunder. Numbers 6:24-26 pronounces blessing with peace.

STEP 6

Application

Next time you hear thunder, pause and say verse 3 and 10. The God who thunders is your Father.

Practice “ascribing” today: give God the glory when something goes well, instead of keeping it.

Pray verse 11 for your church and family.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ascribe glory and strength to God, in your own words.
- Worship him in the splendor of holiness.
- Ask him to give you his peace.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 125

“Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!”

REVELATION 5:12

DAY 873 · WEEK 125

Revelation 4:1-5:14

The throne room; the Lamb takes the scroll

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 25 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 4:1-5:14. John is taken up into the throne room of heaven. Notice the worship around the throne, the sealed scroll, the weeping that turns to praise, and the surprising appearance of the Lamb.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the letters to the churches, John is invited through an open door into heaven, where the rest of the book is seen from the perspective of the throne. The scene recalls Isaiah 6, Ezekiel 1, and Daniel 7. The throne is the central fact of the universe, and the question of Revelation 4 and 5 is: who is worthy to carry out God's plan for history, as symbolized in the scroll? For persecuted Christians who feel that Caesar holds power, this is the vision they need.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "At once I was in the Spirit, and behold, a throne stood in heaven, with one seated on the throne" (4:2).
2. "Holy, holy, holy, is the Lord God Almighty, who was and is and is to come!" (4:8).
3. "Worthy are you, our Lord and God, to receive glory and honor and power, for you created all things" (4:11).
4. "Weep no more; behold, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has conquered" (5:5).
5. "A Lamb standing, as though it had been slain" (5:6).
6. "For you were slain, and by your blood you ransomed people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation" (5:9).

7. “Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!” (5:12).

8. “To him who sits on the throne and to the Lamb be blessing and honor and glory and might forever and ever!” (5:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John is called up through an open door and immediately is in the Spirit before a throne. The one seated on it is described only in terms of gemstones, jasper and carnelian, with a rainbow like an emerald around it. He is not described in human form, because he is beyond description. Around the throne are twenty-four elders on thrones, dressed in white with golden crowns, probably representing the whole people of God (the twelve tribes and twelve apostles). Lightning and thunder come from the throne. Before it burn seven torches, which are the seven spirits of God, and there is a sea of glass like crystal. Four living creatures, full of eyes, like the seraphim of Isaiah 6, never cease to say: “Holy, holy, holy, is the Lord God Almighty, who was and is and is to come!” When they give glory, the elders fall down and cast their crowns before the throne, saying: “Worthy are you, our Lord and God, to receive glory and honor and power, for you created all things, and by your will they existed and were created.” Heaven’s first act is worship of the Creator.

In chapter 5, John sees in the right hand of the one on the throne “a scroll written within and on the back, sealed with seven seals.” This is a scroll of God’s purposes for the world, a will or deed that must be opened for its judgments and blessings to come to pass. A mighty angel asks, “Who is worthy to open the scroll and break its seals?” No one in heaven or on earth or under the earth is found worthy. John weeps loudly. If no one can open it, God’s purposes for history, for his people, and for creation cannot be carried out. But an elder says, “Weep no more; behold, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has conquered, so that he can open the scroll and its seven seals.”

John listens for the Lion, but when he looks, he sees “a Lamb standing, as though it had been slain, with seven horns and with seven eyes, which are the seven spirits of God sent out into all the earth.” He heard “Lion” and saw “Lamb.” This is the central image of the book: Christ conquers by sacrifice, through his death. He bears the marks of slaughter but stands alive. His seven horns signify complete power, and his seven eyes complete knowledge. He takes the scroll from the right hand of the one seated on the throne, and the whole of heaven erupts in a new song: “Worthy are you to take the scroll and to open its seals, for you were slain, and by your blood you ransomed people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation, and you have made them a kingdom and priests to our God, and they shall reign on the earth.”

Then the circle of praise widens: myriads of angels, “ten thousand times ten thousand and thousands of thousands,” saying with a loud voice: “Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!” And finally every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and in the sea: “To him who sits on the throne and to the Lamb be blessing and honor and glory and might forever and ever!” The four living creatures say “Amen,” and the elders fall down and worship. The Lamb shares the worship given to the one on the throne. This is the best answer to the question of what Revelation is about: the Lamb who was slain holds the scroll of history.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 6:1-4 and Ezekiel 1 are the sources for the throne and the creatures. Daniel 7:9-10 shows the Ancient of Days enthroned. Genesis 49:9-10 is the background of the Lion of Judah, and Isaiah 11:1, 10 of the Root of David. Isaiah 53:7 and John 1:29 speak of the Lamb. Exodus 12 is the Passover lamb. Daniel 12:4 and Ezekiel 2:9-10 mention sealed scrolls. Philippians 2:9-11 describes every creature confessing Christ. Colossians 1:15-20 describes his supremacy. Ephesians 1:9-10 speaks of God’s plan for the fullness of time. Revelation 1:5-6 uses the same kingdom and priests language.

STEP 6

Application

Spend five minutes simply worshiping today, with no requests. Use the words of 4:8, 4:11, and 5:12.

When you feel that history is out of control, picture the throne and the Lamb holding the scroll.

Think about how Jesus conquered. How might it change how you respond to a situation where you want to win?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship God as holy, holy, holy.
- Thank the Lamb who was slain and has ransomed people for God.
- Add your voice to the song of every creature.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 125

“Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!”

REVELATION 5:12

DAY 874 · WEEK 125

Revelation 6:1-17

The seven seals, the four horsemen

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 17 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 6:1-17. The Lamb opens the first six of the seven seals. Read it as a picture of the forces at work in history between Christ's first coming and his return, and notice the cry of the martyrs and the response of the world to the wrath of the Lamb.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the beginning of the unfolding of the scroll, with four horsemen modeled on Zechariah 1 and 6, and with words that recall Jesus' own description of the age in Matthew 24: conquest, war, famine, death, persecution, and cosmic upheaval. Interpreters have read the seals in different ways: as events leading up to the end (futurist), as the general pattern of the whole age (idealist), as events of the first century (preterist), or as the course of history (historicist). Many see in them what Jesus described as "the beginning of the birth pains" (Matthew 24:8). In every view, it is the Lamb who opens each seal, which means that all of history is under his authority.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Now I watched when the Lamb opened one of the seven seals" (v. 1).
2. "And its rider had a bow, and a crown was given to him, and he came out conquering, and to conquer" (v. 2).
3. "It was granted to its rider to take peace from the earth, so that people should slay one another" (v. 4).
4. "And do not harm the oil and wine!" (v. 6).
5. "And its rider's name was Death, and Hades followed him" (v. 8).

6. “How long before you will judge and avenge our blood on those who dwell on the earth?” (v. 10).

7. “Told to rest a little longer, until the number of their fellow servants and their brothers should be complete” (v. 11).

8. “For the great day of their wrath has come, and who can stand?” (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first four seals are four horsemen. Each is summoned by one of the living creatures: “Come!” The first, on a white horse, has a bow and a crown and “came out conquering, and to conquer.” Interpreters disagree about the rider. Some see Christ (compare 19:11, where Christ rides a white horse), or the gospel going out in conquest. Others see a counterfeit, the spirit of military conquest, because the horsemen that follow are all evils. The second, on a red horse, takes peace from the earth so that people slay one another, with a great sword: war and violence. The third, on a black horse, holds a balance. A quart of wheat for a denarius, a day’s wage, means famine prices: a worker could buy only enough for himself, with nothing for his family. But the oil and wine are not harmed, as though a limit were set on the famine. The fourth, on a pale horse, is Death, with Hades following, “given authority over a fourth of the earth, to kill with sword and with famine and with pestilence and by wild beasts.” Notice the repeated “it was given”: they have authority only as far as God permits.

The fifth seal moves from the earth to the altar in heaven. John sees “the souls of those who had been slain for the word of God and for the witness they had borne.” They cry out, “O Sovereign Lord, holy and true, how long before you will judge and avenge our blood on those who dwell on the earth?” This is the cry of every martyr and every victim of injustice, and God hears it. It is not a request for private revenge but for God’s justice to be shown. Each is given a white robe and told “to rest a little longer, until the number of their fellow servants and their brothers should be complete, who were to be killed as they themselves had been.” God has a plan and a timetable, and the suffering of his people is part of it.

The sixth seal brings cosmic upheaval: a great earthquake, the sun black as sackcloth, the moon like blood, stars falling, the sky vanishing, every mountain and island moved. This is the language that the prophets used for the day of the Lord. Everyone, kings, great ones, rich, strong, slave and free, hides in caves and calls on the mountains and rocks, “Fall on us and hide us from the face of him who is seated on the throne, and from the wrath of the Lamb, for the great day of their wrath has come, and who can stand?” The Lamb, who is gentle, is also the judge. The wrath of the Lamb is the final answer to the cry of the martyrs.

The chapter ends with a question that the next chapter answers: “Who can stand?” The answer is those who are sealed by God (chapter 7). Until then, the church lives in an age of war, famine, death, and persecution, and the Lamb is on the throne.

STEP 5

Connection

Zechariah 1:7-11 and 6:1-8 are the sources for the horsemen. Matthew 24:4-14 describes the same pattern of conquest, wars, famines, and persecution. Ezekiel 14:21 mentions four judgments. Genesis 4:10 speaks of the blood that cries out. Psalm 79:5, 13:1-2, and Habakkuk 1:2 ask “how long?” Luke 18:7-8 promises justice for those who cry to God. Isaiah 13:10, 34:4, and Joel 2:30-31 use cosmic language. Hosea 10:8 and Luke 23:30 describe calling on mountains. Malachi 3:2 asks who can stand. Romans 12:19 says vengeance belongs to the Lord.

STEP 6

Application

When news of wars, famines, and disasters weighs on you, remember that each seal is opened by the Lamb. He is not surprised.

Pray for persecuted Christians around the world, using the martyrs’ cry, “how long?”

Think about your readiness to stand before God. Thank Christ that the one who judges is the one who died for you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that nothing happens in history outside his authority.
- Tell him what makes you afraid about the state of the world.
- Ask him to give you patience while you wait.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 125

“Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!”

REVELATION 5:12

DAY 875 · WEEK 125

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Revelation 5:12 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!"

REVELATION 5:12

REST

Meditation

Count the attributes in this one verse: power, wealth, wisdom, might, honor, glory, blessing. Seven, the number of completeness. Everything good that anyone could give to anyone is given to the Lamb. And he is worthy, not because of what he has but because of what he did: he was slain.

Think about who the Lamb is. He is the Son of God, and he took on flesh, bore the sins of the world, and was killed. Heaven's greatest worship is for the one who was slaughtered. This reveals what God values. Not conquest by force, but love poured out. Worth is measured at the cross.

This verse can be sung in the car, whispered in a hospital, or shouted at a graveside. When your worth is questioned, or when you feel powerless, remember that the worthy one died for you. Say it aloud, and add your voice to the angels' choir.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the letters to the churches and the opening of the seals. Revelation 3 gave Jesus' words to Sardis (alive in name only), Philadelphia (faithful with little power, given an open door), and Laodicea (lukewarm and self-satisfied, with Christ knocking at the door). Three psalms reflected on the way of the blessed (Psalm 1), the glory of creation and the word (Psalm 19), and the voice of the LORD in the storm (Psalm 29). Revelation 4 and 5 brought us into the throne room, with the worship of the Creator and the Lion who is a Lamb, worthy to open the scroll because he was slain and ransomed people from every nation. Revelation 6 showed the Lamb opening six seals: conquest, war, famine, death, the cry of the martyrs, and the wrath of the Lamb, ending with the question, "who can stand?"

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus tells Laodicea, "Behold, I stand at the door and knock." Is there an area where you have been keeping him outside? What would it look like to open the door today?

John expected a Lion and saw a Lamb. How does the way Jesus won, through sacrifice, change the way you think about strength, success, and winning?

The martyrs cry, "How long?" and are told to rest a little longer. What are you waiting on God for? How can you trust that he hears?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Worship the Lamb who was slain.

Thank him that he holds the scroll of history.

Rest in his hand.

DAY 876 · WEEK 126

Revelation 7:1-8:13

The 144,000 and the great multitude; the seventh seal

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 30 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 7:1-8:13. Chapter 7 is an interlude between the sixth and seventh seals, answering the question “who can stand?” Chapter 8 opens the seventh seal and introduces the first trumpets. Notice the contrast between what John hears and what he sees.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

At the close of chapter 6, the world cries out, “who can stand?” Chapter 7 answers: the servants of God who are sealed. Like the pause in a symphony before the finale, this chapter shows the security of God’s people before the next round of judgments. It is also one of the most debated chapters in the book, because of the identity of the 144,000. Readers should note the pattern John uses elsewhere: he hears one thing and sees another (the Lion and the Lamb in chapter 5), so that the two parts interpret each other.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Do not harm the earth or the sea or the trees, until we have sealed the servants of our God on their foreheads” (7:3).
2. “And I heard the number of the sealed, 144,000, sealed from every tribe of the sons of Israel” (7:4).
3. “A great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb” (7:9).
4. “Salvation belongs to our God who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb!” (7:10).
5. “They have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb” (7:14).

6. “For the Lamb in the midst of the throne will be their shepherd, and he will guide them to springs of living water” (7:17).
7. “When the Lamb opened the seventh seal, there was silence in heaven for about half an hour” (8:1).
8. “The smoke of the incense, with the prayers of the saints, rose before God from the hand of the angel” (8:4).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Four angels stand at the four corners of the earth, holding back the four winds. Another angel with the seal of the living God cries out, “Do not harm the earth or the sea or the trees, until we have sealed the servants of our God on their foreheads.” The seal marks ownership and protection, the opposite of the mark of the beast later. Then John hears the number: 144,000, twelve thousand from each of the twelve tribes of Israel (with Dan omitted and Manasseh included in the list).

Who are they? Christians have given different answers. Some, especially dispensational interpreters, believe they are ethnic Israelites, perhaps converted Jews in a future tribulation. Others believe they are the church, the new Israel, the whole people of God described in the language of the old covenant, which the New Testament elsewhere applies to the church (Galatians 6:16; James 1:1; 1 Peter 1:1; Revelation 21:12-14). The number is twelve times twelve times a thousand, a symbol of completeness. The tribes are listed as an army ready for battle (Numbers 1-2), the sealed ones.

The next scene supports the second reading. “After this I looked, and behold, a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb, clothed in white robes, with palm branches in their hands.” As in chapter 5, John hears a number (the 144,000) and then sees a multitude beyond number. This echoes God’s promise to Abraham of descendants like the stars (Genesis 15:5; 22:17). It is the same people seen from two angles: Israel as an ordered army and the nations as a countless crowd. The multitude cries, “Salvation belongs to our God who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb!” and the angels, elders, and creatures respond with a sevenfold doxology.

An elder asks, “Who are these, clothed in white robes, and from where have they come?” And answers: “These are the ones coming out of the great tribulation. They have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb.” This is a paradox: robes washed in blood become white. The great tribulation is understood by some as a future period at the end of the age, and by others as the whole age of the church’s suffering. Either way, those who endure are cleansed only by the blood of Christ. Their destiny is beautiful: “Therefore

they are before the throne of God, and serve him day and night in his temple; and he who sits on the throne will shelter them with his presence. They shall hunger no more, neither thirst anymore… For the Lamb in the midst of the throne will be their shepherd, and he will guide them to springs of living water, and God will wipe away every tear from their eyes." The Lamb is a shepherd, another paradox.

Chapter 8 opens the seventh seal. The result is silence: "there was silence in heaven for about half an hour." After the praise, a hush before the final events. Then seven angels are given seven trumpets. Another angel stands at the golden altar with a censer and "much incense to offer with the prayers of all the saints." The smoke of the incense, with the prayers of the saints, rises before God. Then the angel fills the censer with fire from the altar and throws it on the earth: thunder, lightning, earthquake. The prayers of the saints (like the martyrs' cry in 6:10) are answered with judgment. The first four trumpets echo the plagues of Egypt: hail and fire mixed with blood burning a third of the earth; a burning mountain thrown into the sea; a star called Wormwood poisoning a third of the waters; a third of the sun, moon, and stars struck. These judgments are partial (a third), warnings meant to lead to repentance. An eagle flying overhead cries, "Woe, woe, woe to those who dwell on the earth," for three more trumpets remain.

STEP 5

Connection

Ezekiel 9:4-6 and 2 Corinthians 1:22 speak of God's seal. Ephesians 1:13 and 4:30 say believers are sealed with the Holy Spirit. Genesis 12:3, 15:5, and Romans 4:16-18 speak of Abraham's multitude. Galatians 3:7-9, 29 and 6:16 call believers the Israel of God and Abraham's offspring. Leviticus 23:40-43 and John 12:13 mention palm branches. Daniel 12:1 and Matthew 24:21 speak of great tribulation. Isaiah 25:8 and 49:10 are echoed in 7:16-17. Psalm 23:1-2 and John 10:11 show the shepherd. Habakkuk 2:20 calls for silence before the LORD. Exodus 7-10 recounts the plagues. Psalm 141:2 speaks of prayer as incense.

STEP 6

Application

Place yourself in the great multitude. Read 7:9-17 slowly, and thank Christ for washing your robes in his blood.

When you face a trial, recall verse 17: the Lamb is your shepherd, and he will wipe away every tear.

Pray with the confidence that your prayers rise before God like incense and are not lost.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for sealing and keeping his servants.

Thank him for a people from every nation.

Ask him to keep you faithful through tribulation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 126

"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death."

REVELATION 12:11

DAY 877 · WEEK 126

Revelation 9:1-11:19

The trumpets; the two witnesses; the kingdom proclaimed

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 9:1-11:19. This is a long and demanding reading with the fifth and sixth trumpets, the little scroll, the two witnesses, and the seventh trumpet. Read it as a story of judgment, witness, and the arrival of the kingdom, and watch for its connection to Daniel, Ezekiel, and Zechariah.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The trumpets sound a series of judgments that echo the plagues of Egypt, with the first four affecting nature (chapter 8) and the next three, called "woes," affecting humanity. As with the seals, the trumpets are divided into six, followed by an interlude (10:1-11:14), and then a seventh. The interlude shows the church's role in this period: John eats a little scroll and the church prophesies as two witnesses. The seventh trumpet brings the announcement that the kingdom has come.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I saw a star fallen from heaven to earth, and he was given the key to the shaft of the bottomless pit" (9:1).
2. "Did not repent of the works of their hands" (9:20).
3. "In the days of the trumpet call to be sounded by the seventh angel, the mystery of God would be fulfilled, just as he announced to his servants the prophets" (10:7).
4. "It was sweet as honey in my mouth, but when I had eaten it my stomach was made bitter" (10:10).
5. "And I will grant authority to my two witnesses, and they will prophesy for 1,260 days, clothed in sackcloth" (11:3).

6. “But after the three and a half days a breath of life from God entered them, and they stood up on their feet” (11:11).

7. “The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ, and he shall reign forever and ever” (11:15).

8. “The ark of his covenant was seen within his temple” (11:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The fifth trumpet brings a star fallen from heaven, given the key to the shaft of the bottomless pit. Smoke rises, and out of the smoke come locusts with power like scorpions. They are told not to harm the grass but only people who do not have the seal of God on their foreheads, torturing them for five months. Their king is the angel of the bottomless pit, Abaddon or Apollyon, the Destroyer. This is a picture of demonic torment let loose on unbelievers, limited in extent and duration. The sixth trumpet releases four angels bound at the Euphrates, with an army of 200 million horsemen whose horses have heads like lions and tails like serpents. A third of mankind is killed. Yet the rest “did not repent of the works of their hands nor give up worshiping demons and idols,” nor repent of murders, sorceries, sexual immorality, or thefts. This is the tragedy of the passage: judgment does not by itself change hearts.

Then comes an interlude. A mighty angel, wrapped in a cloud with a rainbow over his head and a face like the sun, with feet like pillars of fire, stands with one foot on the sea and one on the land, holding a little scroll open in his hand. Seven thunders speak, but John is told to seal up what they said. The angel swears by the Creator that there will be no more delay: “in the days of the trumpet call to be sounded by the seventh angel, the mystery of God would be fulfilled, just as he announced to his servants the prophets.” John is told to eat the little scroll, as Ezekiel did (Ezekiel 3:1-3). “It was sweet as honey in my mouth, but when I had eaten it my stomach was made bitter.” The word of God is sweet to receive and bitter to deliver, because it includes judgment and suffering. He must prophesy again about many peoples, nations, languages, and kings.

Chapter 11 begins with John measuring the temple of God and the altar and those who worship there, but not the outer court, which is given over to the nations, who will trample the holy city for forty-two months. The measuring is a picture of God’s protection of his people (the true temple, understood by many as the church) while the world persecutes them. The forty-two months (also 1,260 days or “a time, times, and half a time” from Daniel 7:25) is a symbolic period of limited, intense testing. During this time, God grants authority to “my two witnesses.” They prophesy in sackcloth. They are described as two olive trees and two lampstands (Zechariah 4), with power like Moses and Elijah, to shut the sky and strike

the earth with plagues. Interpreters disagree about who they are: two literal prophets in the end times, or, as many hold, the church in its witnessing role, the two representing the legal requirement of two witnesses (Deuteronomy 19:15). When they finish their testimony, the beast from the bottomless pit kills them, and their bodies lie in the street of the great city "where their Lord was crucified," while the world gloats and exchanges gifts. But "after the three and a half days a breath of life from God entered them, and they stood up on their feet, and great fear fell on those who saw them." They are called up to heaven in a cloud. The witnessing church may seem defeated, but it will be vindicated.

The seventh trumpet brings loud voices in heaven: "The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ, and he shall reign forever and ever." The elders fall on their faces: "We give thanks to you, Lord God Almighty, who is and who was, for you have taken your great power and begun to reign. The nations raged, but your wrath came, and the time for the dead to be judged, and for rewarding your servants." The tense is almost past: the victory is announced as accomplished. The chapter closes with the opening of God's temple in heaven and the sight of the ark of his covenant, with flashes of lightning, rumblings, thunder, an earthquake, and heavy hail. The ark signifies God's covenant faithfulness; he keeps his promises, and the covenant community is secure.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 7-10 and Joel 1-2 are the background of the plagues and locusts. Ezekiel 2:8-3:3 and Jeremiah 15:16 describe eating the scroll. Daniel 7:25, 8:13-14, and 12:7 give the time periods. Zechariah 4:1-14 describes the two olive trees. Deuteronomy 19:15 requires two witnesses. 1 Kings 17:1 and Exodus 7:17-19 relate to the powers of Elijah and Moses. Psalm 2 is the background of 11:15-18. Luke 21:24 mentions Jerusalem trampled. Ephesians 2:19-22 describes the church as God's temple. Hebrews 9:4 mentions the ark of the covenant. Matthew 28:19-20 and Acts 1:8 describe the church's witness.

STEP 6

Application

Think about the sweet and bitter nature of God's word. What in Scripture is sweet to you, and what is hard to swallow? Receive both.

Consider your role as a witness. Pray that God would give you boldness to speak, even when it is not welcomed.

Read 11:15 aloud as a statement of faith about the future: the kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you see of the hardness of the human heart.

Ask him to give you a heart that repents.

Thank him that his judgments are just and the kingdom is his.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 126

"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death."

REVELATION 12:11

DAY 878 · WEEK 126

Psalm 141

Let my prayer be counted as incense

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 141. It is an evening prayer of David, asking God to hear, to guard the lips, and to keep the heart from evil. Notice the image of prayer as incense and the unusual request to be corrected.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 141 is a psalm of David written in a time of danger, when enemies threatened and temptation pressed. It is a prayer of an individual who feels vulnerable in two ways: to external enemies and to internal temptations. The image of prayer as incense and the lifting of hands as the evening sacrifice would have been strongly associated with the temple. In Revelation, the prayers of the saints are described as incense before the throne (5:8; 8:3-4), and the psalm is the origin of the image.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “O LORD, I call upon you; hasten to me! Give ear to my voice when I call to you!” (v. 1).
2. “Let my prayer be counted as incense before you, and the lifting up of my hands as the evening sacrifice!” (v. 2).
3. “Set a guard, O LORD, over my mouth; keep watch over the door of my lips!” (v. 3).
4. “Do not let my heart incline to any evil” (v. 4).
5. “Let a righteous man strike me; let it be a kindness; let him rebuke me; it is oil for my head” (v. 5).
6. “But my eyes are toward you, O GOD, my Lord; in you I seek refuge; leave me not defenseless!” (v. 8).

7. “Keep me from the trap that they have laid for me and from the snares of evildoers!” (v. 9).

8. “Let the wicked fall into their own nets, while I pass by safely” (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David starts with urgency: “O LORD, I call upon you; hasten to me!” Then he makes a request that shapes the whole psalm: “Let my prayer be counted as incense before you, and the lifting up of my hands as the evening sacrifice!” In the temple, incense was burned on the golden altar morning and evening, and its fragrant smoke rose up to God. David asks that his prayer would be received as acceptably as the evening incense, though he has no temple at the moment. The same image appears in Revelation 5:8, where the elders hold golden bowls of incense, “which are the prayers of the saints,” and in 8:3-4, where an angel offers much incense with the prayers of all the saints.

Then David turns to his lips and heart, an unexpected request when his enemies are pressing in. “Set a guard, O LORD, over my mouth; keep watch over the door of my lips! Do not let my heart incline to any evil, to busy myself with wicked deeds in company with men who work iniquity; and let me not eat of their delicacies!” He knows that the greater danger is not what enemies do to him but what he might do in anger or temptation. He asks God to guard his speech, his desires, and his company.

Verse 5 is surprising: “Let a righteous man strike me; let it be a kindness; let him rebuke me; it is oil for my head; let my head not refuse it.” He welcomes correction from a faithful friend. Wounds from a friend are faithful (Proverbs 27:6). Those who want to grow in holiness need people who will tell them the truth. This is the opposite of the wicked, who in verse 4 invite him to feast with them, and whose “delicacies” are the pleasures of sin.

The psalm ends with confident refuge. The leaders of the wicked will be thrown down, and their bones scattered at the mouth of Sheol. “But my eyes are toward you, O GOD, my Lord; in you I seek refuge; leave me not defenseless!” He asks to be kept from the trap and snares. “Let the wicked fall into their own nets, while I pass by safely.” In Christ we have the greater sacrifice and intercessor, who ever lives to make intercession for us. Our prayers rise before the throne through his priesthood, and nothing we pray is lost.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 30:1-9 describes the altar of incense. Luke 1:8-10 shows Zechariah offering incense while the people pray outside. Revelation 5:8 and 8:3-4 connect incense and prayer. Proverbs 27:5-6, 9 speaks of rebuke from a friend. Psalm 19:14 and James 3:2-12 pray for guarded

speech. Psalm 119:37 asks for eyes turned from vanity. Matthew 6:13 asks to be led not into temptation. Hebrews 7:25 and Romans 8:34 describe Christ's intercession. Hebrews 13:15 speaks of a sacrifice of praise. Psalm 57:6 and Proverbs 26:27 speak of falling into one's own trap.

STEP 6

Application

Make this your evening prayer tonight. Lift your hands or bow your head, and offer your prayer as incense.

Ask a trusted friend where they see a blind spot in you. Receive it as "oil for your head."

Pray for a guard over your lips in a specific conversation you will have tomorrow.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to receive your prayer as incense.

Ask him to guard your mouth and your heart.

Thank him that he hears the cry of the afflicted.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 126

"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death."

REVELATION 12:11

DAY 879 · WEEK 126

Psalm 150

Praise him with trumpet and harp

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 150. It is the last psalm of the Psalter, a burst of praise with trumpet and harp. Notice where, why, how, and who: the psalm answers each of these questions in six short verses.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 150 is the final psalm of the five books of Psalms, a doxology that closes the whole collection with an explosion of praise. Every verse is a command to praise, and the word "praise" occurs thirteen times in six verses. Today we read it with the trumpets of Revelation in mind: in Israel, trumpets were sounded for both worship and war, and in Revelation, trumpet blasts announce judgment, but they end with the loudest praise of all (11:15). We will read it again at the end of the book, where we will see it as a closing word of the whole Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Praise God in his sanctuary; praise him in his mighty heavens!" (v. 1).
2. "Praise him for his mighty deeds" (v. 2).
3. "Praise him according to his excellent greatness!" (v. 2).
4. "Praise him with trumpet sound; praise him with lute and harp!" (v. 3).
5. "Praise him with tambourine and dance; praise him with strings and pipe!" (v. 4).
6. "Praise him with sounding cymbals; praise him with loud clashing cymbals!" (v. 5).
7. "Let everything that has breath praise the LORD!" (v. 6).
8. "Praise the LORD!" (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm answers four questions. Where should we praise? “In his sanctuary” and “in his mighty heavens”: on earth in the place of worship and in heaven, everywhere. Why? “For his mighty deeds” and “according to his excellent greatness.” We praise him for what he has done (creation, redemption, deliverance) and for who he is. How? With every instrument they knew. “Praise him with trumpet sound; praise him with lute and harp! Praise him with tambourine and dance; praise him with strings and pipe! Praise him with sounding cymbals; praise him with loud clashing cymbals!” This includes wind, strings, and percussion, with dance and with the whole body. True worship is not limited to one style or mood; it engages every part of life. Who? “Let everything that has breath praise the LORD!” Every living creature has breath from God, and so all should return it in praise.

This psalm comes at the end of a book that is full of laments, confessions, complaints, and questions. After all of that, the book ends in praise. It tells us that praise is the destination of the life of faith. When we reach the end of the road, everything we have prayed about will have led to this.

Now, read it with Revelation. In the book, the trumpets of Revelation 8 and 9 are sounded by angels as judgment on a rebellious world. But the seventh trumpet in 11:15 brings a different sound: loud voices in heaven proclaiming that the kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord. And in 14:2 and 15:2, the harps of God accompany the song of the redeemed. The trumpets that announce judgment lead to praise because the Judge is also the Redeemer. The final victory means that the cries of the oppressed and the praise of God’s people fill the universe.

Notice also the order: God is praised in his sanctuary, and in his heavens. The two meet in the book of Revelation, where the heavenly worship is opened up to the earthly church, and where the new Jerusalem comes down out of heaven. One day there will be no separation: all of creation will join the song. Until then, we praise by faith.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Chronicles 15:16-28 and 2 Chronicles 5:11-14 describe temple music. Numbers 10:1-10 and Joshua 6 describe trumpets in worship and war. Exodus 15:20-21 shows Miriam with tambourines. 2 Samuel 6:14-15 shows David dancing before the LORD. Psalm 98:4-6 also calls for trumpets and harps. Revelation 5:8-14, 11:15-18, 14:2-3, and 15:2-4 describe heavenly worship. Colossians 3:16 and Ephesians 5:19 call for singing in the church. Psalm 148 and 149 are the other closing psalms of praise. Hebrews 13:15 calls for a sacrifice of praise.

STEP 6

Application

Praise God out loud today, with music if you can. Use a hymn or a worship song that expresses his greatness.

Ask which of the four questions (where, why, how, who) you need to grow in: praising in more places, for more reasons, with more of your body, or inviting more people.

Notice when you take a breath today, and let each be a reminder to praise the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God in his sanctuary and in his mighty heavens, in your own words.

Praise him for his mighty deeds.

Let everything that has breath praise him, and add your own.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 126

"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death."

REVELATION 12:11

DAY 880 · WEEK 126

Psalm 148

Praise the LORD from the heavens

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 148. This psalm calls the whole creation to praise, from the angels to the sea monsters to kings and children. Notice the two halves: praise from the heavens (vv. 1-6) and praise from the earth (vv. 7-14).

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 148 is one of the Hallel psalms at the end of the Psalter (146 to 150). It is a hymn calling all of creation to praise the LORD. It has no named author, and it does not tell a story but sings an invitation. It prepares us for the last two weeks of Revelation, where every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and in the sea joins in worship (5:13). Today we will see the whole creation as a choir, with Christ as the horn that God has raised up.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Praise the LORD! Praise the LORD from the heavens; praise him in the heights!” (v. 1).
2. “Praise him, all his angels; praise him, all his hosts!” (v. 2).
3. “Praise him, sun and moon, praise him, all you shining stars!” (v. 3).
4. “Let them praise the name of the LORD! For he commanded and they were created” (v. 5).
5. “Praise the LORD from the earth, you great sea creatures and all deeps” (v. 7).
6. “Kings of the earth and all peoples, princes and all rulers of the earth!” (v. 11).
7. “Let them praise the name of the LORD, for his name alone is exalted” (v. 13).
8. “He has raised up a horn for his people, praise for all his saints” (v. 14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts above: “Praise the LORD from the heavens; praise him in the heights!” The angels and hosts, the sun and moon and stars, the highest heavens and the waters above the heavens are told to praise. The reason is given: “Let them praise the name of the LORD! For he commanded and they were created. And he established them forever and ever; he gave a decree, and it shall not pass away.” Creation praises by being what God made it to be, obeying his command. The heavens do not need words to praise him; their ordered existence proclaims his wisdom.

The second half comes down to the earth. “Praise the LORD from the earth, you great sea creatures and all deeps, fire and hail, snow and mist, stormy wind fulfilling his word! Mountains and all hills, fruit trees and all cedars! Beasts and all livestock, creeping things and flying birds!” The psalmist lists everything: sea monsters (which in other cultures were symbols of chaos and are here put in their place), weather, mountains, trees, animals. Then humanity: “Kings of the earth and all peoples, princes and all rulers of the earth! Young men and maidens together, old men and children!” The call goes from rulers to children, with no one left out. It includes every age and every rank.

The reason for human praise is the same: “Let them praise the name of the LORD, for his name alone is exalted; his majesty is above earth and heaven.” And then the psalm gives a particular reason for the people of God to praise: “He has raised up a horn for his people, praise for all his saints, for the people of Israel who are near to him.” A horn is a symbol of strength and, in this context, a ruler or savior from the house of David. Zechariah, in Luke 1:69, uses the same image for Jesus: “He has raised up a horn of salvation for us in the house of his servant David.” The creation praises its Maker, and the church praises the one who has saved it.

This psalm gives dignity to everything in creation, a reminder that the world is a stage for God’s glory. It also shows that our praise is part of something bigger. When we sing, we join the sun, the stars, the sea creatures, the trees, and the angels. And in Revelation 5:13, John hears “every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and in the sea, and all that is in them, saying, To him who sits on the throne and to the Lamb be blessing and honor and glory and might forever and ever!” Psalm 148 is the first draft of that chorus.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1 recounts the creation that Psalm 148 praises. Psalm 19:1-4 and 96:11-13 also have creation praising God. Isaiah 55:12 has trees clapping their hands. Job 38-41 shows the Creator’s care for the whole creation. Luke 1:69 uses the horn for Christ. Psalm 132:17 speaks

of a horn for David. Romans 8:19-23 describes creation waiting for redemption. Colossians 1:16-20 describes all things created through and reconciled to Christ. Revelation 5:13 and 21:1-5 show all creation worshiping. Philippians 2:10-11 describes every knee bowing.

STEP 6

Application

Take a walk outside and notice one thing from each group in the psalm: the sky, the weather, a plant, an animal. Let each prompt a short prayer of praise.

Think about the whole range of ages and ranks in your church. Ask how you can include someone from a different age or background in worship.

Thank Christ for being the horn that God has raised up for his people.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God from the heavens and from the earth.
- Add your voice to the voices of angels and creation.
- Tell him what in creation moves you to praise.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 126

"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death."

REVELATION 12:11

DAY 881 · WEEK 126

Revelation 12:1-13:18

The woman and the dragon; the two beasts

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 35 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 12:1-13:18. This is among the most symbolic parts of the book. Read it as a drama in three parts: the woman and the dragon, the war in heaven, and the two beasts who serve the dragon. Notice the repeated pattern of the dragon's power and the saints' victory.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the seventh trumpet, the book moves to a second half, which looks at the spiritual conflict behind history. John is shown the "great sign" of a woman and a dragon, then the beasts. These are not simply events to come but pictures of realities that have been present since the fall: Satan's enmity against the offspring of the woman (Genesis 3:15), the state's tendency to demand worship (Daniel 3 and 7), and the false religion that serves it. For first-century Christians under Rome, the beast from the sea was plainly the empire and its emperors, and the beast from the land was the priesthood and propaganda of the imperial cult. For us, these chapters expose similar powers in every age, and may point to a final climax of their rebellion.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Behold, a great red dragon, with seven heads and ten horns" (12:3).
2. "One who is to rule all the nations with a rod of iron" (12:5).
3. "That ancient serpent, who is called the devil and Satan, the deceiver of the whole world" (12:9).
4. "They have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony" (12:11).

5. “He knows that his time is short” (12:12).
6. “A beast rising out of the sea, with ten horns and seven heads” (13:1).
7. “The book of life of the Lamb who was slain” (13:8).
8. “Here is a call for the endurance and faith of the saints” (13:10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

A great sign appears in heaven: a woman clothed with the sun, with the moon under her feet and a crown of twelve stars, about to give birth. She represents the people of God, from whom the Messiah comes: Israel in the Old Testament, and the church in the New (some also see Mary as the model). A great red dragon stands before her, with seven heads, ten horns, and seven diadems, ready to devour her child. His tail sweeps down a third of the stars (fallen angels). The child is born, “a male child, one who is to rule all the nations with a rod of iron” (Psalm 2:9), and is caught up to God and to his throne. This compresses the life of Christ: his birth, his rule, and his ascension, with the cross implied. The woman flees into the wilderness, where she is nourished for 1,260 days.

Then war breaks out in heaven. Michael and his angels fight the dragon, and “the great dragon was thrown down, that ancient serpent, who is called the devil and Satan, the deceiver of the whole world.” He is identified fully: the serpent of Genesis 3, the accuser. A loud voice proclaims: “Now the salvation and the power and the kingdom of our God and the authority of his Christ have come, for the accuser of our brothers has been thrown down.” Many see this as the effect of Christ’s death and ascension, when Satan’s accusing power was broken. And the means of victory: “And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death.” The church wins not by force but by the blood of Christ, faithful witness, and willingness to die. But “woe to you, O earth and sea, for the devil has come down to you in great wrath, because he knows that his time is short!” A defeated enemy is the most dangerous; he turns to persecute the woman and the rest of her offspring, “those who keep the commandments of God and hold to the testimony of Jesus.”

Chapter 13 introduces the dragon’s two agents. The first beast rises out of the sea with ten horns, seven heads, and blasphemous names. It resembles Daniel’s four beasts combined. The dragon gives it his power and throne and great authority. One of its heads seems to have a mortal wound that is healed (a parody of the resurrection). The whole earth marvels and worships the dragon and the beast: “Who is like the beast, and who can fight against it?” This mocks the praise of God, “Who is like you, O LORD?” It is allowed for forty-two months to utter blasphemies and “to make war on the saints and to conquer them.” All will worship it,

“everyone whose name has not been written before the foundation of the world in the book of life of the Lamb who was slain.” And in the middle comes a call for the saints: “Here is a call for the endurance and faith of the saints.”

The second beast rises out of the earth, with two horns like a lamb but speaking like a dragon. It exercises the authority of the first beast and makes the earth worship it, performing signs and deceiving the inhabitants. It orders an image of the beast and causes all to be marked on the right hand or forehead, “so that no one can buy or sell unless he has the mark, that is, the name of the beast or the number of its name.” It is a parody of the Spirit, as the first beast is a parody of Christ. The number is given: “This calls for wisdom: let the one who has understanding calculate the number of the beast, for it is the number of a man, and his number is 666.” Many early Christians understood this by the Hebrew letters as pointing to Nero Caesar; others see it as a symbol of human imperfection (falling short of seven, repeated three times); others as a future individual. In every approach, the lesson is the same: the world powers that demand ultimate loyalty are in the service of the dragon, but they are allowed only a limited time, and the Lamb’s book of life cannot be erased.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 3:15 is the first promise of the woman’s offspring and the serpent. Isaiah 66:7-9 and Micah 5:2-3 mention the birth of the Messiah. Psalm 2:9 is quoted in 12:5. Daniel 7:2-8 describes four beasts rising from the sea. Daniel 3 tells of the demand to worship an image. Job 1-2 and Zechariah 3:1-2 show Satan as accuser. Romans 8:33-34 answers the accuser. Luke 10:18 and John 12:31 describe Satan’s fall and judgment. 2 Thessalonians 2:3-12 describes the man of lawlessness. 1 John 2:18 and 4:3 speak of antichrists. Matthew 24:24 mentions false signs. Exodus 15:11 and Psalm 35:10 ask, “Who is like you?”

STEP 6

Application

When you feel overwhelmed by evil, remember how the saints conquer: by the blood of the Lamb, the word of their testimony, and not loving their lives even unto death.

Examine where the world’s powers ask for your ultimate loyalty (nation, money, ideology, security). Choose one area where you need to worship only the Lamb.

Pray for Christians who are living under regimes that demand allegiance contrary to Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for being the child who rules the nations.

Thank him that the accuser is conquered by his blood.

Ask him for courage to speak your testimony.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 126

“And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death.”

REVELATION 12:11

DAY 882 · WEEK 126

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Revelation 12:11 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death."

REVELATION 12:11

REST

Meditation

This verse holds the secret of the Christian's victory over Satan. It has three parts.

First, "the blood of the Lamb." This is the ground of our victory. The accuser has charges against us, but the blood answers every charge. We do not defeat him with our own righteousness but with Christ's sacrifice, which has already paid the price.

Second, "the word of their testimony." This is the means. Christians speak the truth about Jesus, about what he has done and who he is, in the face of the lie. Testimony is not only for the pulpit; it includes the plain way we say what we believe at home, at work, and in suffering.

Third, "they loved not their lives even unto death." This is the cost. Those who are willing to lose their lives for Christ cannot be controlled by fear of death. A person who is not afraid to die cannot be intimidated.

When you feel under spiritual attack, say this verse aloud. Rest in the blood, speak the testimony, and let go of fear.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read through the middle of Revelation. Chapter 7 answered the question "who can stand?" with the sealed servants of God and the great multitude from every nation, robes washed in the blood of the Lamb. Chapter 8 opened the seventh seal with silence in heaven, and the prayers of the saints rising as incense before the throne. Chapters 9 to 11 sounded trumpets of judgment, showed the bitter-sweet little scroll, the two witnesses who are killed and raised, and the seventh trumpet announcing that the kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord. Psalm 141 taught us to pray as incense and to welcome correction. Psalm 150 and Psalm 148 called every creature to praise. Revelation 12 and 13 unveiled the dragon, the woman, and the two beasts, and the church's way of conquering by the blood of the Lamb, the word of testimony, and willingness to die.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Revelation 12:11 gives three ways the saints conquered the accuser. Which of these three do you rely on most, and which do you tend to neglect?

Most of the world did not repent despite the trumpets (9:20-21). What does this tell you about the limits of judgment and the need for grace? Who are you praying for who needs a change of heart?

The call of 13:10 is for endurance and faith. What is the hardest area in which you need endurance right now? How can the Lamb's example in Revelation 5 strengthen you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for the victory won by his blood.

Ask him for courage to testify.

Rest in his victory.

DAY 883 · WEEK 127

Revelation 14:1-15:8

The 144,000 on Mount Zion; the harvest; the bowls

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 14:1-15:8. Chapter 14 shows a series of visions of the Lamb and his people, followed by announcements of judgment. Chapter 15 introduces the final seven plagues, with the song of Moses and of the Lamb. Notice the contrast between the Lamb's people on Mount Zion and the world under the beast.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the dragon and the beasts, the book gives a series of contrasts to encourage the persecuted church. Where the beast's followers have its mark on their foreheads, the Lamb's followers have his name and his Father's name. These chapters sit between the unveiling of the evil powers and the final outpouring of God's wrath. They announce the fall of Babylon, the final harvest, and the song that celebrates God's justice. Some interpreters see these scenes as parallel to previous ones, returning to the same period from another angle; others see them as moving forward in a chronological sequence.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "On Mount Zion stood the Lamb, and with him 144,000 who had his name and his Father's name written on their foreheads" (14:1).
2. "It is these who follow the Lamb wherever he goes" (14:4).
3. "Another angel flying directly overhead, with an eternal gospel to proclaim to those who dwell on earth, to every nation and tribe and language and people" (14:6).
4. "Fallen, fallen is Babylon the great" (14:8).
5. "Blessed are the dead who die in the Lord from now on" (14:13).

6. “One like a son of man, with a golden crown on his head, and a sharp sickle in his hand” (14:14).
7. “The song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb” (15:3).
8. “All nations will come and worship you, for your righteous acts have been revealed” (15:4).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John sees the Lamb standing on Mount Zion with the 144,000, who have the name of the Lamb and his Father written on their foreheads. This contrasts with the mark of the beast. A sound from heaven like many waters and loud thunder, and like harpists playing on their harps, accompanies a new song before the throne. The 144,000 are described as those who have not defiled themselves with women (probably a figurative way of saying they have kept themselves pure from the spiritual adultery of idolatry), who “follow the Lamb wherever he goes,” and who were redeemed as firstfruits for God and the Lamb. “In their mouth no lie was found, for they are blameless.” As in chapter 7, they are the whole redeemed people seen as a purified army.

Then three angels. The first flies in midheaven with “an eternal gospel to proclaim to those who dwell on earth, to every nation and tribe and language and people. And he said with a loud voice, Fear God and give him glory, for the hour of his judgment has come, and worship him who made heaven and the earth.” Even in these final scenes, the gospel is proclaimed to every nation. The second angel announces, “Fallen, fallen is Babylon the great,” the first mention of the city that will be described fully in chapters 17 and 18. The third warns that anyone who worships the beast will drink the wine of God’s wrath and be tormented, with no rest day or night. Then a call: “Here is a call for the endurance of the saints, those who keep the commandments of God and their faith in Jesus.” A voice from heaven says, “Blessed are the dead who die in the Lord from now on.” “Blessed indeed,” says the Spirit, “that they may rest from their labors, for their deeds follow them!” This is among the most comforting verses in the book for those who grieve: those who die in Christ are blessed.

Next come two images of harvest. One like a son of man on a white cloud with a sharp sickle reaps the earth’s harvest, which is ripe. An angel then gathers the vintage of the earth and throws it into the great winepress of the wrath of God, and blood flows to a horse’s bridle for 1,600 stadia. These images of judgment are drawn from Joel 3:13 and Isaiah 63:1-6. Interpreters differ on whether the first harvest is the gathering of the righteous (as grain) and the second is the judgment (as grapes), or whether both refer to judgment. What is clear is that the Lord of the harvest has the final say.

Chapter 15 introduces “another sign in heaven, great and amazing: seven angels with seven plagues, which are the last, for with them the wrath of God is finished.” John sees those who had conquered the beast standing beside a sea of glass mingled with fire, with harps of God in their hands. They sing “the song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb”: “Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy. All nations will come and worship you, for your righteous acts have been revealed.” Like Israel after the Red Sea (Exodus 15), the redeemed sing on the shore after their deliverance. The song combines the two great redemptions: the exodus and the cross. Then the temple is opened, and the seven angels come out dressed in pure bright linen, and one of the four living creatures gives them seven golden bowls full of God’s wrath. The temple fills with smoke from God’s glory and power, and none can enter until the plagues are completed.

STEP 5

Connection

Joel 3:13 and Isaiah 63:1-6 are the images of harvest and winepress. Exodus 15:1-18 is the song of Moses. Deuteronomy 32 is another song of Moses. Psalm 86:9-10 and 98:1-3 speak of the nations worshiping. Isaiah 21:9 and Jeremiah 51:8 announce the fall of Babylon. Matthew 13:24-43 describes the harvest at the end of the age. Matthew 24:14 says the gospel will be preached to all nations. Hebrews 4:9-11 speaks of rest. 1 Corinthians 15:58 says our labor is not in vain. Exodus 40:34-35 and 1 Kings 8:10-11 show the glory filling the temple.

STEP 6

Application

Remember, when you grieve a believer who has died, that their deeds follow them and they rest from their labors (14:13).

Ask whom you can tell the “eternal gospel,” and pray for opportunity this week.

Sing a song of deliverance today, and use the words of 15:3-4.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God that great and amazing are his deeds.

Ask him to give you a heart that fears and glorifies him.

Thank him for those who endure.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 127

“Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy.”

REVELATION 15:3-4

DAY 884 · WEEK 127

Psalm 2

Why do the nations rage?

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 2. It is one of the royal psalms, quoted again and again in the New Testament. Read it as four scenes: the nations rebel (vv. 1-3), God laughs (vv. 4-6), the Son speaks (vv. 7-9), and the kings are warned (vv. 10-12).

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 2 was probably used at the coronation of a king in David's line, when surrounding nations might revolt against a new ruler. But its language is too large for any ordinary Israelite king: the Lord's anointed is called God's Son and given the nations as his inheritance. The New Testament sees its fulfillment in Jesus. Early Christians prayed it in Acts 4 when persecuted. Revelation draws on it repeatedly (2:26-27; 11:15-18; 12:5; 19:15), so it is one of the keys to the book.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain?" (v. 1).
2. "The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the LORD and against his anointed" (v. 2).
3. "He who sits in the heavens laughs" (v. 4).
4. "As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill" (v. 6).
5. "You are my Son; today I have begotten you" (v. 7).
6. "Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage, and the ends of the earth your possession" (v. 8).
7. "Serve the LORD with fear, and rejoice with trembling" (v. 11).

8 “Blessed are all who take refuge in him” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a question of astonishment: “Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain?” It is a futile revolt. “The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the LORD and against his anointed, saying, Let us burst their bonds apart and cast away their cords from us.” They think of God’s rule as a prison. The picture is one of the whole world, with its political powers, in rebellion against God and his Messiah. This is exactly the setting of Revelation: the dragon, the beasts, and the kings of the earth raging against the Lamb.

Then God’s response: “He who sits in the heavens laughs; the Lord holds them in derision.” It is not a happy laugh but the laughter of one who sees that the attempt is hopeless. Then he speaks to them in his wrath: “As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill.” The rebels cannot undo what God has done.

The King himself speaks next: “I will tell of the decree: The LORD said to me, You are my Son; today I have begotten you.” This is the promise to David (2 Samuel 7:14) and finds its ultimate fulfillment in Jesus, whom the New Testament declares to be the Son at his baptism, transfiguration, and resurrection (Acts 13:33; Romans 1:4; Hebrews 1:5). “Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage, and the ends of the earth your possession. You shall break them with a rod of iron and dash them in pieces like a potter’s vessel.” Revelation takes this promise and applies it to Christ and to those who share his rule (2:26-27; 12:5; 19:15). This does not mean we have violent power; it means that his kingdom will conquer all that opposes it.

Finally, a warning with an invitation: “Now therefore, O kings, be wise; be warned, O rulers of the earth. Serve the LORD with fear, and rejoice with trembling. Kiss the Son, lest he be angry, and you perish in the way, for his wrath is quickly kindled. Blessed are all who take refuge in him.” To kiss the Son is to submit to him and to honor him. The psalm began with the first Psalm’s word for the blessed man and ends with the same word for all who take refuge in the Son. There is a way out of judgment: take refuge in him. The same Son who will judge the nations invites us into his shelter. And so the great conflict of Revelation is not a conflict between equal powers: it is between a rebellious world and the King whom God has installed.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Samuel 7:12-16 is the promise to David. Acts 4:23-31 quotes the psalm in prayer. Acts 13:32-33, Hebrews 1:5, and 5:5 quote verse 7. Matthew 3:17 and 17:5 echo it at Jesus' baptism and transfiguration. Revelation 2:26-27, 11:15-18, 12:5, 19:15 draw on it. Philippians 2:9-11 describes the nations bowing to Jesus. Ephesians 1:20-22 speaks of his rule. Psalm 110:1-2 speaks of his enemies as his footstool. Psalm 1:1 and 2:12 frame the opening of the Psalter with "blessed." John 3:36 warns about the Son's wrath.

STEP 6

Application

When news about the nations is discouraging, say verse 4 to yourself. God is not anxious.

Take refuge in the Son today by naming something you fear and entrusting it to Christ.

Pray for rulers by name, that they would kiss the Son and be wise.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what raging and plotting you see.
- Thank him for the Son he has set on Zion.
- Take refuge in the Son.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 127

"Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy."

REVELATION 15:3-4

DAY 885 · WEEK 127

Psalm 46

God is our refuge

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 46. It is the psalm behind Martin Luther's hymn "A Mighty Fortress." Notice the three stanzas separated by "Selah," each ending in the refrain, "The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 46 is a song of the sons of Korah, probably written after a great deliverance, perhaps the rescue of Jerusalem from Sennacherib's army in 701 BC (Isaiah 36-37). It sets the stability of God's city against the chaos of earthquakes and storms and the raging of nations. In our reading of Revelation, it provides a counterpoint to the plagues and wars: in the middle of upheaval, the people of God have a river, a city, and a God who is present.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble" (v. 1).
2. "Therefore we will not fear though the earth gives way" (v. 2).
3. "There is a river whose streams make glad the city of God" (v. 4).
4. "God is in the midst of her; she shall not be moved; God will help her when morning dawns" (v. 5).
5. "The nations rage, the kingdoms totter; he utters his voice, the earth melts" (v. 6).
6. "The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress" (v. 7).
7. "He makes wars cease to the end of the earth" (v. 9).
8. "Be still, and know that I am God. I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted in the earth!" (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a statement of faith: “God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble.” He is not a distant helper; he is very present, close at hand. The consequence is: “Therefore we will not fear though the earth gives way, though the mountains be moved into the heart of the sea, though its waters roar and foam, though the mountains tremble at its swelling.” This is the worst-case scenario: creation itself coming apart. Even then, God’s people do not fear. It is like many of the images in Revelation, where mountains move and seas turn to blood.

The second stanza turns to the city of God. “There is a river whose streams make glad the city of God, the holy habitation of the Most High.” Jerusalem had no river, only a gentle spring, Gihon. The river is symbolic, a picture of God’s presence bringing life and gladness. In Ezekiel 47 and in Revelation 22:1-2, this river becomes a great reality flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb. “God is in the midst of her; she shall not be moved; God will help her when morning dawns.” While the sea roars and mountains shake, the city is safe, because God dwells in it. “The nations rage, the kingdoms totter; he utters his voice, the earth melts.” Notice the same verb used for the nations raging in Psalm 2. Their raging is answered by a word from God.

The third stanza invites us to look at God’s works: “Come, behold the works of the LORD, how he has brought desolations on the earth. He makes wars cease to the end of the earth; he breaks the bow and shatters the spear; he burns the chariots with fire.” The Lord ends wars, which we long to see. And then the famous command: “Be still, and know that I am God. I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted in the earth!” “Be still” means to cease striving, to let go. It is addressed to God’s people in trouble, and also to the raging nations. The way to face the chaos is not to panic but to be still, and know that he is God.

The refrain is the center: “The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress.” The Lord of hosts commands every army, and the God of Jacob is the God who stayed faithful to a flawed man. He is both powerful and personal. And in Christ, he is Immanuel, God with us. At the end of Revelation, the same truth is proclaimed: “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man” (21:3). The city of God, with its river, is the final home of his people.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 8:8-10 and 37:33-38 relate to Immanuel and the deliverance of Jerusalem. Genesis 2:10-14 and Ezekiel 47:1-12 describe rivers of life. Revelation 21:2-3 and 22:1-2 show the city and river. Psalm 48 and 87 also celebrate the city of God. Psalm 2 uses the same word for nations

raging. Matthew 1:23 gives the name Immanuel. Exodus 14:13-14 shows God fighting for a people who are still. Isaiah 30:15 and 40:31 speak of quietness and strength. Hebrews 12:22-28 speaks of an unshakable kingdom. Romans 8:31-39 expresses similar confidence.

STEP 6

Application

Take five minutes of silence today, and put a name on the thing you are anxious about. Then say, “Be still, and know that I am God.”

Memorize verse 1. It can be prayed in any trouble.

Name a place in your life where the ground is shaking (health, work, relationships). Place it in the hands of the God who is a very present help.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you fear, and say that he is your refuge and strength.

Be still, and know that he is God.

Thank him that he is with you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 127

“Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy.”

REVELATION 15:3-4

DAY 886 · WEEK 127

Psalm 93

The LORD reigns; he is robed in majesty

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 93. It is a short psalm that announces the reign of the LORD and speaks of him as mightier than the floods. Read it as a brief hymn that opens a series of enthronement psalms (93, 95-99).

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 93 has no author, but it is one of the "The LORD reigns" psalms. It was probably sung in worship celebrating God's kingship, perhaps at a festival. In the ancient world, floods and seas represented chaos and the forces that threaten order. This psalm declares that the LORD is mightier than all of them. It helps us read Revelation, in which seas, beasts, and floods seem to threaten the people of God, but in which the throne is secure.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD reigns; he is robed in majesty" (v. 1).
2. "He has put on strength as his belt" (v. 1).
3. "Yes, the world is established; it shall never be moved" (v. 1).
4. "Your throne is established from of old; you are from everlasting" (v. 2).
5. "The floods have lifted up their voice" (v. 3).
6. "Mightier than the thunders of many waters, mightier than the waves of the sea, the LORD on high is mighty!" (v. 4).
7. "Your decrees are very trustworthy" (v. 5).
8. "Holiness befits your house, O LORD, forevermore" (v. 5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a proclamation: “The LORD reigns; he is robed in majesty; the LORD is robed; he has put on strength as his belt.” The Hebrew word for “reigns” can also be rendered “has become king,” and the psalm was probably sung to celebrate God’s kingship. He is clothed like a king in majesty and strength. “Yes, the world is established; it shall never be moved.” Because God is king, the world is stable. The world is not a random accident but is held in place by his rule.

Next, the eternity of his throne: “Your throne is established from of old; you are from everlasting.” Before the world existed, God reigned. His throne is not a recent achievement. This is why the elders in Revelation 4 praise the one who was and is and is to come.

Then the threat: “The floods have lifted up, O LORD, the floods have lifted up their voice; the floods lift up their roaring.” Three times, the floods are mentioned, building like waves. They represent every power that threatens: chaotic nature, hostile nations, and demonic forces. The floods are loud, and the repeated phrasing suggests that they will not stop. But the next verse puts them in perspective: “Mightier than the thunders of many waters, mightier than the waves of the sea, the LORD on high is mighty!” The floods roar, but God is mightier. His voice, in Psalm 29, is heard over the waters.

The psalm ends with two statements about God’s word and house. “Your decrees are very trustworthy; holiness befits your house, O LORD, forevermore.” His commands can be trusted, and his dwelling place is holy. The God who rules the floods is also the God who speaks reliably and calls his people to holiness.

For Christians, the picture is complete in Jesus, who stilled the storm with a word (Mark 4:39), walked on the waves, and calmed the seas that frightened his disciples. They said in awe, “Who then is this, that even wind and sea obey him?” This psalm is the answer. And in Revelation, the Lamb stands on the throne above the chaos, and the sea of glass before the throne is calm (4:6). In the new creation, “the sea was no more” (21:1): the symbol of chaos is gone.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 29:3, 10 also pictures God enthroned over the flood. Psalm 95-99 are other enthronement psalms. Exodus 15:18 declares that the LORD will reign forever. Mark 4:35-41 shows Jesus calming the storm. Job 38:8-11 shows God setting limits for the sea. Psalm 65:7 and 89:9 speak of stilling the waves. Isaiah 43:2 promises that waters will not overwhelm. Revelation 4:6, 15:2, and 21:1 mention the sea. Revelation 11:15 and 19:6 announce that God reigns. Hebrews 12:28 speaks of receiving an unshakable kingdom.

STEP 6

Application

When you feel like the floods are lifting up their voice (anxiety, news, conflict), say verse 4 aloud.

Thank God for the stability of his rule. Name three things in your life that rest on it.

Pray that your church's life would reflect the holiness that befits his house.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise God as king, robed in majesty.

Thank him that the world is established and cannot be moved.

Tell him what you are holding that you want him to uphold.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 127

"Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy."

REVELATION 15:3-4

DAY 887 · WEEK 127

Psalm 97

The LORD reigns; let the earth rejoice

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 97. It is another enthronement psalm. Notice how creation and the nations respond to the arrival of the King, and how the psalm ends with joy for the righteous.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 97 continues the theme of the previous psalm: the LORD reigns. It uses imagery of theophany (God's appearing), with clouds, fire, lightning, and melting mountains, similar to Sinai. It also speaks of the humiliation of idols and the joy of God's people. It reads like a commentary on Revelation 19, where the multitude cries, "Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns," and the idols and the powers of evil are overthrown.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD reigns, let the earth rejoice; let the many coastlands be glad!" (v. 1).
2. "Righteousness and justice are the foundation of his throne" (v. 2).
3. "The mountains melt like wax before the LORD, before the Lord of all the earth" (v. 5).
4. "The heavens proclaim his righteousness, and all the peoples see his glory" (v. 6).
5. "All worshipers of images are put to shame" (v. 7).
6. "O you who love the LORD, hate evil! He preserves the lives of his saints" (v. 10).
7. "Light is sown for the righteous, and joy for the upright in heart" (v. 11).
8. "Rejoice in the LORD, O you righteous, and give thanks to his holy name!" (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Where Psalm 93 spoke of the stability of God's reign, Psalm 97 shows its effects. The first response is joy: "The LORD reigns, let the earth rejoice; let the many coastlands be glad!" Even distant lands are invited. But the reign of God is also awesome: "Clouds and thick darkness are all around him; righteousness and justice are the foundation of his throne." God's throne rests on righteousness and justice; he rules fairly. "Fire goes before him and burns up his adversaries all around. His lightnings light up the world; the earth sees and trembles. The mountains melt like wax before the LORD." This is similar to the plagues and cosmic disturbances of Revelation. The Lord's coming is overwhelming, and all of creation responds.

"The heavens proclaim his righteousness, and all the peoples see his glory." Then a result for false religion: "All worshipers of images are put to shame, who make their boast in worthless idols; worship him, all you gods!" Idols are shown to be empty. The gods themselves are told to worship the LORD, a statement that echoes Revelation, where the demonic powers are defeated. Zion hears and is glad, and the daughters of Judah rejoice "because of your judgments, O LORD." God's judgments are a cause of rejoicing for his people, because they mean justice at last. "For you, O LORD, are most high over all the earth; you are exalted far above all gods."

Then the moral application: "O you who love the LORD, hate evil! He preserves the lives of his saints; he delivers them from the hand of the wicked." Love for God and hatred of evil go together. And the promise: "Light is sown for the righteous, and joy for the upright in heart." The metaphor is of seeds in the ground: light and joy are planted for the righteous and will spring up. It may not look like it now, in a world that persecutes the saints, but a harvest of light and joy is coming. This is the same theme as in Revelation 21, where there is no more night and no more tears.

The final invitation is to rejoice: "Rejoice in the LORD, O you righteous, and give thanks to his holy name!" Believers face the future with joy. In Revelation, the final celebration is of the marriage supper of the Lamb. For now, we rejoice by faith, trusting that the day will come when the evidence matches the promise.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 19:16-19 and Psalm 18:7-15 describe God's appearing. Psalm 96, 98, and 99 are other enthronement psalms. Isaiah 42:17 and 44:9-20 mock idols. Hebrews 1:6 quotes the Septuagint of verse 7, "Let all God's angels worship him." Psalm 89:14 says righteousness and justice are the foundation of his throne. Revelation 19:1-8 shows the multitude rejoicing at

God's judgments. Romans 12:9 says to abhor what is evil. Psalm 126:5-6 speaks of sowing with tears and reaping with joy. Revelation 21:23-25 pictures the city without need of the sun. Habakkuk 3:3-6 is another theophany.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a situation where you cannot yet see justice, and picture "light sown" there. Pray for the harvest.

Hate what God hates this week. Ask him to show you something you have been tolerating.

Rejoice in the LORD today, even if circumstances are hard, and give thanks to his holy name.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Rejoice that the LORD reigns.
- Thank him for light sown for the righteous.
- Ask him to give you gladness in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 127

"Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy."

REVELATION 15:3-4

DAY 888 · WEEK 127

Revelation 16:1-21

The seven bowls of wrath

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 16:1-21. The seven bowls of God's wrath are poured out in a rapid series, resembling the plagues of Egypt. Notice the repeated refusal to repent, the declaration that God's judgments are just, and the final cry, "It is done!"

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The bowls are the last of the series of seven (seals, trumpets, bowls). They are described as final, bringing the wrath of God to completion. Unlike the trumpets, which affected a third of the earth, the bowls are total. Interpreters differ on whether the three series are sequential, parallel, or progressively intensifying cycles that cover the same period from different angles. In any reading, the point is the same: God's judgment on the beast's kingdom is just and certain, and he will bring evil to account.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Go and pour out on the earth the seven bowls of the wrath of God" (v. 1).
2. "Harmful and painful sores came upon the people who bore the mark of the beast" (v. 2).
3. "Yes, Lord God the Almighty, true and just are your judgments!" (v. 7).
4. "They did not repent and give him glory" (v. 9).
5. "Its water was dried up, to prepare the way for the kings from the east" (v. 12).
6. "Behold, I am coming like a thief! Blessed is the one who stays awake" (v. 15).
7. "And they assembled them at the place that in Hebrew is called Armageddon" (v. 16).
8. "It is done!" (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

A loud voice from the temple commands the seven angels to pour out the bowls. The first brings sores on those with the mark of the beast, like the boils of Egypt. The second turns the sea to blood, killing every living thing in it. The third turns the rivers and springs to blood, and the angel of the waters declares: “Just are you, O Holy One, who is and who was, for you brought these judgments. For they have shed the blood of saints and prophets, and you have given them blood to drink. It is what they deserve!” A voice from the altar adds, “Yes, Lord God the Almighty, true and just are your judgments!” This is the answer to the martyrs’ cry in 6:10: God’s judgments are retributive, matched to the sin. The fourth bowl scorches people with fire from the sun, “and they cursed the name of God who had power over these plagues. They did not repent and give him glory.” This is the tragic refrain: even under judgment, hearts remain hard. The fifth falls on the throne of the beast, and its kingdom is plunged into darkness; people gnaw their tongues in anguish and curse God, but do not repent of their deeds.

The sixth bowl dries up the great river Euphrates “to prepare the way for the kings from the east.” Three unclean spirits like frogs come from the mouths of the dragon, the beast, and the false prophet, performing signs and going out to assemble the kings of the whole world “for battle on the great day of God the Almighty.” Then the voice interrupts: “Behold, I am coming like a thief! Blessed is the one who stays awake, keeping his garments on, that he may not go about naked and be seen exposed!” This is a call to watchfulness in the midst of the vision. “And they assembled them at the place that in Hebrew is called Armageddon.” The name probably means “Mount of Megiddo,” a site of famous battles in Israel’s history (Judges 5; 2 Kings 23:29), though Megiddo is a plain, not a mountain, so it is a symbolic name for the place where the final battle is gathered. Interpreters differ on whether this is a literal military conflict at the end of history or a symbol of the final spiritual confrontation between the forces of evil and God. Notice that in the account no battle is described here; it is deferred to 19:19-21, where the beast and the kings gather against the rider on the white horse, and the battle is won by his word.

The seventh bowl is poured into the air, and a loud voice from the throne says, “It is done!” Flashes of lightning, rumblings, thunder, and a great earthquake, such as there has never been, split the great city into three parts, and the cities of the nations fall. “God remembered Babylon the great, to make her drain the cup of the wine of the fury of his wrath.” Every island flees, mountains vanish, and great hailstones, about a hundred pounds each, fall from heaven on people, and they curse God. The chapter ends as it began, with human hearts unrepentant.

This chapter is hard to read. We should neither dwell on it with relish nor skip over it. It tells us that God takes evil seriously. The same Lord who offers mercy will not let evil go unanswered. It also tells us something about the human heart: apart from grace, even the experience of God's judgment does not produce repentance. We need new hearts, and Christ gives them.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 7-10 recounts the plagues of Egypt. Psalm 79:1-3 and Isaiah 49:26 relate to those who shed blood. Genesis 9:6 and Luke 11:49-51 speak of the blood of the prophets. Isaiah 11:15-16 and Jeremiah 50:38 describe drying up the Euphrates. Judges 5:19 and 2 Kings 23:29-30 mention Megiddo. Ezekiel 38-39 describes a final assault against God's people. Matthew 24:43-44 and 1 Thessalonians 5:2-4 describe the coming as a thief. Revelation 19:11-21 shows the final battle. John 19:30, "It is finished." Romans 2:4-5 speaks of an unrepentant heart.

STEP 6

Application

Stay awake: think of one habit that helps you stay alert and watchful in your faith, and strengthen it this week.

Pray for someone with a hard heart, that God would grant repentance.

When you are struck by the justice of God's judgments, thank Christ for taking the wrath for those who trust in him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that his judgments are true and just.
- Ask him to give you a tender heart that repents.
- Thank him that he hears the blood of his saints.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 127

“Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy.”

REVELATION 15:3-4

DAY 889 · WEEK 127

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Revelation 15:3-4 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy."

REVELATION 15:3-4

REST

Meditation

This is a song sung by those who have come through great trouble. Standing on the shore of the sea of glass, with harps in hand, they sing about the character of God, not about themselves.

"Great and amazing are your deeds." They praise what he has done. "Just and true are your ways." They praise how he does it: with justice and truth, even when the ways are painful or hard to understand. The people who sing this have seen suffering, and they still say his ways are just.

"Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy." The right response to a holy God is reverent fear and glad glory.

The song combines the song of Moses and the song of the Lamb: the exodus and the cross. When you feel confused by events, sing this to remind yourself of what will be said at the end.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the second half of Revelation's visions of conflict. Chapter 14 showed the Lamb with his people on Mount Zion, the eternal gospel proclaimed to every nation, the fall of Babylon, the blessing on those who die in the Lord, and the final harvest. Chapter 15 gave us the song of Moses and the Lamb. Four psalms framed the reign of God: Psalm 2 (the nations rage, but God's Son is enthroned), Psalm 46 (God is our refuge, be still), Psalm 93 (the LORD reigns, mightier than the floods), and Psalm 97 (the LORD reigns, light is sown for the righteous). Chapter 16 poured out the seven bowls of wrath: judgments that are just, and hearts that do not repent, ending with the cry "It is done!"

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Psalm 2 says, "Blessed are all who take refuge in him." What would it mean for you to take refuge in Christ this week, specifically from something that frightens you?

In Revelation 16, people suffer terrible judgments and still do not repent. What does this tell you about the human heart, and how does it increase your gratitude for grace?

Revelation 14:13 says those who die in the Lord are blessed, because they rest from their labors and their deeds follow them. How does this change how you think about death, and about the work you are doing now?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that great and amazing are his deeds.

Thank him for his reign.

Rest in him.

DAY 890 · WEEK 128

Revelation 17:1-18:24

Babylon the great falls

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 42 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 17:1-18:24. Two chapters describe the fall of Babylon the great, first as a prostitute riding a beast, then as a great city mourned by merchants and kings. Notice the contrast between Babylon and the Bride of the Lamb, who appears in chapter 19.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In the Old Testament, Babylon was the empire that destroyed Jerusalem and took Israel into exile, and it became the symbol of human pride and opposition to God, from the tower of Babel (Genesis 11) onward. In the first century, Babylon was a code name for Rome, the city on seven hills that dominated the Mediterranean world. In Revelation, Babylon is both of these and more: the world system organized against God, seductive, wealthy, and violent, in every age. The prophets Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel used a similar language for the cities of Babylon and Tyre. John's readers would hear the echoes.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And I saw a woman sitting on a scarlet beast that was full of blasphemous names" (17:3).
2. "I saw the woman, drunk with the blood of the saints, the blood of the martyrs of Jesus" (17:6).
3. "They will make war on the Lamb, and the Lamb will conquer them, for he is Lord of lords and King of kings" (17:14).
4. "Fallen, fallen is Babylon the great!" (18:2).
5. "Come out of her, my people, lest you take part in her sins, lest you share in her plagues" (18:4).

6. “I sit as a queen, I am no widow, and mourning I shall never see” (18:7).
7. “And slaves, that is, human souls” (18:13).
8. “Rejoice over her, O heaven, and you saints and apostles and prophets, for God has given judgment for you against her!” (18:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

One of the seven angels with the bowls invites John to see “the judgment of the great prostitute who is seated on many waters, with whom the kings of the earth have committed immorality.” In the Spirit, John sees a woman sitting on a scarlet beast with seven heads and ten horns, dressed in purple and scarlet, adorned with gold, jewels, and pearls, holding a golden cup full of abominations. On her forehead is a name of mystery: “Babylon the great, mother of prostitutes and of earth’s abominations.” She is “drunk with the blood of the saints, the blood of the martyrs of Jesus.” John marvels greatly, and the angel explains the mystery. The beast “was, and is not, and is to come” (a parody of God’s “who is and who was and who is to come”). The seven heads are seven mountains (an allusion to Rome’s seven hills) and also seven kings. The ten horns are ten kings who receive authority for a brief time. They give their power to the beast and “will make war on the Lamb, and the Lamb will conquer them, for he is Lord of lords and King of kings, and those with him are called and chosen and faithful.” The woman “is the great city that has dominion over the kings of the earth.” Interpreters debate the exact historical identification of the kings, but the point is that every earthly power that opposes Christ is doomed. And, strikingly, the beast and the ten kings turn on the prostitute and destroy her: evil devours itself.

In chapter 18, the scene shifts to the city’s fall. An angel with great authority lights up the earth: “Fallen, fallen is Babylon the great! She has become a dwelling place for demons, a haunt for every unclean spirit.” The reason is that all nations have drunk of the wine of her immorality, and the merchants of the earth have grown rich from the power of her luxurious living. Then a voice from heaven calls God’s people: “Come out of her, my people, lest you take part in her sins, lest you share in her plagues.” It is a call to separation. Believers are to live in the world without being of it, refusing its idolatries and injustices, and ready to leave if loyalty to Christ requires it. The prophets said the same of the ancient Babylon (Jeremiah 51:45).

The woman’s self-image is: “I sit as a queen, I am no widow, and mourning I shall never see.” Because of her pride, “in a single day her plagues will come, death and mourning and famine, and she will be burned up with fire.” The kings of the earth, merchants, and shipmasters mourn her: “Alas! Alas! You great city.” The merchants weep because “no one buys their cargo anymore.” The cargo list is long: gold, silver, jewels, fine linen, spices, wine,

grain, cattle, horses and chariots, “and slaves, that is, human souls.” The final item reveals the system’s true cost: human lives sold as commodities. The empire’s wealth was built on trafficking in people. Their grief is not for her but for their profits.

Heaven, however, responds with joy: “Rejoice over her, O heaven, and you saints and apostles and prophets, for God has given judgment for you against her!” A mighty angel throws a stone like a great millstone into the sea: “So will Babylon the great city be thrown down with violence, and will be found no more.” The sounds of harpists, musicians, craftsmen, millstones, lamps, and brides and grooms will cease. “And in her was found the blood of prophets and of saints, and of all who have been slain on earth.” All injustice is judged. The city of man is overthrown to make room for the city of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 10-11 introduces Babel and Babylon. Isaiah 13-14, 21:9, 47, Jeremiah 50-51, and Daniel 4:30 describe ancient Babylon’s pride and fall. Ezekiel 26-28 describes the fall of Tyre. Nahum 3:4 uses prostitution for a city. Hosea 2 and Jeremiah 3 use prostitution for unfaithfulness. 2 Corinthians 6:14-18 and 1 John 2:15-17 call for separation from the world. Isaiah 52:11 and Jeremiah 51:6, 45 say “come out.” Ezekiel 27 lists the merchants of Tyre. Amos 8:4-6 and James 5:1-6 condemn exploiting the poor. 1 Peter 5:13 uses Babylon for Rome.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you are drawn by the glamor and luxury of Babylon. What do you envy or chase that the world offers?

Consider the supply chains and systems you depend on. Ask whether any of them are built on the exploitation of people, and what you can do about it.

Pray for believers living in places of persecution and temptation, that they would be kept faithful.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Worship Jesus as Lord of lords and King of kings.

Thank him that Babylon has fallen and he has won.

Ask him to help you come out of whatever you are entangled with.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 128

“He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen.”

REVELATION 22:20-21

DAY 891 · WEEK 128

Revelation 19:1-20:15

The marriage supper; the rider; the thousand years; final judgment

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 61 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 19:1-20:15. This is a long and important reading, covering the marriage supper of the Lamb, the rider on the white horse, the binding of Satan, the thousand years, and the great white throne. Read slowly, and notice how each scene answers the question of who wins.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the fall of Babylon, heaven erupts in praise, and the book moves to the return of Christ, the final defeat of evil, and the last judgment. Chapter 20 contains the only mention of the "thousand years" in the Bible, and Christians have understood it in three major ways. The book's purpose is not to settle a timetable but to assure the church that the Lamb wins and that evil is finally and fully destroyed.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns" (19:6).
2. "The marriage of the Lamb has come, and his Bride has made herself ready" (19:7).
3. "Blessed are those who are invited to the marriage supper of the Lamb" (19:9).
4. "A white horse! The one sitting on it is called Faithful and True" (19:11).
5. "King of kings and Lord of lords" (19:16).
6. "And bound him for a thousand years" (20:2).
7. "Blessed and holy is the one who shares in the first resurrection!" (20:6).
8. "And if anyone's name was not found written in the book of life, he was thrown into the lake of fire" (20:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

A great multitude in heaven cries out, “Hallelujah! Salvation and glory and power belong to our God, for his judgments are true and just; for he has judged the great prostitute.” These are the only “Hallelujahs” in the New Testament. The twenty-four elders and four living creatures say “Amen,” and a voice from the throne calls all God’s servants to praise. Then the multitude, “like the roar of many waters and like the sound of mighty peals of thunder,” cries, “Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns. Let us rejoice and exult and give him the glory, for the marriage of the Lamb has come, and his Bride has made herself ready; it was granted her to clothe herself with fine linen, bright and pure,” which is “the righteous deeds of the saints.” This is a contrast with the prostitute. The Bride is the church. “Blessed are those who are invited to the marriage supper of the Lamb.” John falls down to worship the angel, but is told, “You must not do that! I am a fellow servant… Worship God. For the testimony of Jesus is the spirit of prophecy.”

Then heaven opens: “a white horse! The one sitting on it is called Faithful and True, and in righteousness he judges and makes war.” His eyes are like a flame of fire, on his head are many diadems, he wears a robe dipped in blood, and his name is “The Word of God.” The armies of heaven follow him on white horses, clothed in fine linen. “From his mouth comes a sharp sword with which to strike down the nations.” Note that the weapon is his word. On his robe and thigh is written the name “King of kings and Lord of lords.” An angel invites the birds to the great supper of God. The beast and the kings gather to make war against him, but the beast and the false prophet are captured and thrown alive into the lake of fire, and the rest are killed by the sword from his mouth. No battle is actually described: the Word speaks and it is done.

In chapter 20, an angel with the key of the bottomless pit seizes “the dragon, that ancient serpent, who is the devil and Satan, and bound him for a thousand years, and threw him into the pit, and shut it and sealed it over him, so that he might not deceive the nations any longer.” Then John sees thrones with those given authority to judge, and the souls of those beheaded for the testimony of Jesus, who “came to life and reigned with Christ for a thousand years.” This is called the first resurrection. “Blessed and holy is the one who shares in the first resurrection! Over such the second death has no power.” After the thousand years, Satan is released for a short time, deceives the nations (Gog and Magog), and surrounds the camp of the saints, but fire comes down from heaven and consumes them, and the devil is thrown into the lake of fire.

Christians have three main views on the millennium. Premillennialists believe Christ returns before a literal thousand-year reign on earth: historic premillennialists hold that the church will go through the tribulation, and dispensational premillennialists hold that the

church is raptured before it. Amillennialists believe the thousand years is symbolic of the present age between Christ's first and second comings, in which Satan is bound in the sense that he cannot prevent the gospel from reaching the nations, and the saints who have died reign with Christ in heaven. Postmillennialists believe that the gospel will bring a golden age before Christ returns. Faithful Christians hold each of these views. The points on which all agree are that Christ will return visibly, there will be a resurrection and judgment, and the final state is the new creation.

The chapter ends with the great white throne, which we examine on Day 892: the dead, great and small, stand before the throne, books are opened, and death and Hades are thrown into the lake of fire. The last enemy is destroyed.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 2 and 110 are the background of the rider's rule with the rod of iron. Isaiah 63:1-6 describes the one whose garments are stained. Ephesians 5:25-32 and 2 Corinthians 11:2 describe the church as the Bride. Isaiah 25:6-9 describes a feast on the mountain. Matthew 22:1-14 and 25:1-13 are parables of the wedding. 2 Thessalonians 2:8 says Christ will destroy the lawless one by the breath of his mouth. Ezekiel 38-39 describes Gog and Magog. John 5:28-29 and 1 Corinthians 15:20-28 speak of resurrection and the last enemy. Colossians 2:15 and Matthew 12:29 speak of binding the strong man.

STEP 6

Application

Praise God today with the word "Hallelujah," and think about what it means: "praise the LORD."

Think of the marriage supper of the Lamb as your future. Ask how it changes what you live for now.

When Christians disagree on the millennium, practice charity. Which parts do all agree on, and how can you focus on them?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Say, "Hallelujah," and tell God why.

Thank him for inviting you to the marriage supper of the Lamb.

Ask him to keep you faithful to the end.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 128

"He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen."

REVELATION 22:20-21

DAY 892 · WEEK 128

Revelation 20:11-15; Matthew 25:31-46; 2 Corinthians 5:10

The Final Judgment

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 20:11-15, Matthew 25:31-46, and 2 Corinthians 5:10. Today is a doctrinal pause on the final judgment. It is a serious subject, so read slowly, and notice both the justice and the mercy that appear in these passages.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Christians have confessed from the earliest days that Christ "will come again to judge the living and the dead." The final judgment is not a minor topic; Jesus spoke of it often, and the apostles preached it. It is meant to produce reverence, sobriety, and urgency, and for believers, thankfulness and hope. We must handle it with care because it concerns real people and eternal consequences.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Then I saw a great white throne and him who was seated on it" (Revelation 20:11).
2. "And I saw the dead, great and small, standing before the throne, and books were opened" (Revelation 20:12).
3. "The dead were judged by what was written in the books, according to what they had done" (Revelation 20:12).
4. "And if anyone's name was not found written in the book of life, he was thrown into the lake of fire" (Revelation 20:15).
5. "He will separate people one from another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats" (Matthew 25:32).

6. “As you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me” (Matthew 25:40).
7. “And these will go away into eternal punishment, but the righteous into eternal life” (Matthew 25:46).
8. “For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, so that each one may receive what is due for what he has done in the body, whether good or evil” (2 Corinthians 5:10).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The final judgment is the public, universal, and final assessment by Christ of every human being at the end of history. The Bible teaches several truths about it.

It is certain. God “has fixed a day on which he will judge the world in righteousness by a man whom he has appointed” (Acts 17:31). Jesus himself is the judge (John 5:22; 2 Timothy 4:1), which means the one who died for sinners is the one before whom all will stand. It is universal: “the dead, great and small.” No one is overlooked or excused.

It is according to truth and works. The books record what each person has done, and the judgment will be perfectly just. Nothing is hidden (Luke 12:2-3; Romans 2:16). Works are the evidence of the heart. Yet no one is saved by works. The decisive question is whether one’s name is in the book of life, the book of the Lamb who was slain (Revelation 13:8; 21:27). Those who are in Christ are declared righteous by faith, and “there is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1). Believers will also appear before the judgment seat of Christ, but not for condemnation. Paul says the judgment will evaluate their works, to bring rewards or loss, “yet so as through fire” (1 Corinthians 3:12-15). Their salvation is secure, and their service will be rewarded by grace. The judgment of the nations in Matthew 25 shows that how people treat Christ’s people (the “least of these”) shows their relationship to him.

It results in two outcomes. The Bible teaches the final separation of the saved and the lost: eternal life and eternal punishment (Matthew 25:46; Daniel 12:2). The majority of Christian teaching throughout history has understood this punishment as conscious and everlasting, and this view has strong support in Matthew 25:41-46, Mark 9:43-48, 2 Thessalonians 1:9, and Revelation 14:11 and 20:10. A minority of evangelicals, including some respected teachers such as John Stott, have argued for conditional immortality or annihilationism, the view that the lost will be destroyed and cease to exist after judgment, pointing to passages that speak of “destruction” and “perishing.” The universalist view, that all will eventually be saved, has been rejected by the church as contrary to Scripture’s clear teaching. We should handle this topic with humility, not with relish. “As I live, declares the Lord GOD, I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked” (Ezekiel 33:11).

What should we do with this doctrine? It should fill us with a sober urgency to share the gospel (2 Corinthians 5:11), with confidence that God will right every wrong (Romans 12:19), with comfort for those who suffer injustice, and with humility, because we also deserve judgment apart from grace. It should lead us to live in a way that is pleasing to the Lord (2 Corinthians 5:9). And it should drive us to Christ, who bore the judgment for all who trust him, so that on that day we can stand in him.

STEP 4

Interpretation

John sees a great white throne. The white signifies purity, and the throne's size signifies the greatness of the occasion. "From his presence earth and sky fled away, and no place was found for them." The old creation cannot stand before the Judge. The dead are raised, "great and small," and stand before the throne. Books are opened, and "another book was opened, which is the book of life." The books record deeds, the book of life records the names of those who belong to the Lamb. The sea, Death, and Hades give up their dead. Then "Death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire. This is the second death, the lake of fire. And if anyone's name was not found written in the book of life, he was thrown into the lake of fire."

Matthew 25 gives a parable of the same event. The Son of Man sits on his throne of glory, and all nations are gathered before him. He separates people as a shepherd separates sheep from goats. To the sheep he says, "Come, you who are blessed by my Father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world." The basis he names is care for the hungry, thirsty, stranger, naked, sick, and imprisoned. They are astonished: when did we do these things? "As you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me." The goats are told to depart into the eternal fire prepared for the devil and his angels. Neither group is aware of the full significance of what they did. The sheep did not do these things to earn a reward; their love was the fruit of a transformed heart. The goats' lack of love revealed that they did not know him.

Paul writes with sobering clarity: "For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ." It says "all," including Christians. And he draws the implication: "Therefore, knowing the fear of the Lord, we persuade others." But he also explains the ground of confidence: "For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Corinthians 5:21). We can look forward to the day not because we are good but because we are covered in Christ's righteousness.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 17:30-31 and Romans 2:5-16 speak of the day of judgment. John 5:22-29 says the Father has given all judgment to the Son. 1 Corinthians 3:10-15 and 4:5 speak of the testing of works. Romans 14:10-12 says we will all stand before God's judgment seat. Hebrews 9:27 says people die once and then face judgment. Ecclesiastes 12:14 says God will bring every deed into judgment. Daniel 12:1-3 speaks of resurrection to everlasting life and contempt. Romans 8:1 and John 5:24 promise no condemnation for believers. 2 Peter 3:7-9 speaks of the patience of God. Ezekiel 18:23 says God takes no pleasure in the death of the wicked.

STEP 6

Application

Take a few minutes to thank Christ for bearing the judgment you deserved. Read Romans 8:1 aloud.

Ask who in your life does not yet know Christ, and pray for them by name. Take one step to speak to them.

Look at Matthew 25 and ask: whom might you serve this week as if you were serving Christ himself?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being judge and also the one who bore judgment for you.
- Tell him what you want to say about the final judgment.
- Pray for someone you love who does not yet trust him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 128

"He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen."

REVELATION 22:20-21

DAY 893 · WEEK 128

Revelation 21:1-22:5

The new creation; the New Jerusalem; the river of life

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 21:1-22:5. This is the climax of the whole Bible: the new heavens and new earth, the New Jerusalem, and the river and tree of life. Read slowly. As you read, think back to the first chapters of Genesis, and notice how many things in the Garden of Eden return here.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The book of Revelation ends with the vision for which the whole Bible has been preparing: God dwelling with his people in a renewed creation. The images are drawn from Isaiah 65-66, Ezekiel 40-48, and Zechariah, and from Genesis 1-3. Where Genesis began with a garden and a marriage, Revelation ends with a city and a marriage. What was lost in the fall is restored and surpassed. This is the goal of the covenants: God with his people. It is why the memory verse for this unit comes from this passage.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and the sea was no more” (21:1).
2. “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God” (21:3).
3. “He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more” (21:4).
4. “Behold, I am making all things new” (21:5).
5. “And its lamp is the Lamb” (21:23).
6. “The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations” (22:2).

7. “No longer will there be anything accursed” (22:3).

8. “They will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads” (22:4).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John sees “a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and the sea was no more.” The sea, a symbol of chaos and separation, is gone. Then he sees “the holy city, new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband.” The city is the people of God, and the image of the bride unites the two. Then the voice from the throne: “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God.” This is the covenant promise, repeated throughout the Old Testament (Leviticus 26:11-12; Ezekiel 37:27): “I will be their God, and they shall be my people.” The tabernacle and temple were pointers; here the reality has arrived. “He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away.” The curse of Genesis 3 is undone.

The one on the throne speaks for the second time in the book: “Behold, I am making all things new.” Not “I am making new things,” but all things new. It is a renewal of creation. “I am the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end. To the thirsty I will give from the spring of the water of life without payment.” Those who conquer will inherit these things, “and I will be his God and he will be my son.” But the cowardly, faithless, detestable, murderers, sexually immoral, sorcerers, idolaters, and all liars will have their portion in the lake of fire. The vision does not hide the stakes.

An angel shows John the Bride, the wife of the Lamb: the holy city, with the glory of God, radiant like a jewel. It has a great high wall with twelve gates, with the names of the twelve tribes of Israel, and twelve foundations with the names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb. Old and new covenant people are united. The city is a perfect cube (12,000 stadia each way), like the Most Holy Place in the temple. The whole city is a holy of holies. The wall is jasper, the city pure gold, clear as glass, and the foundations are adorned with every kind of jewel. The gates are pearls, and the street is pure gold. “And I saw no temple in the city, for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb.” “And the city has no need of sun or moon to shine on it, for the glory of God gives it light, and its lamp is the Lamb.” The nations walk by its light, and the kings of the earth bring their glory into it. Its gates are never shut, for there is no night. “But nothing unclean will ever enter it… but only those who are written in the Lamb’s book of life.”

Chapter 22 returns to Eden. “Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb through the middle of the street of the city; also, on either side of the river, the tree of life with its twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit each month. The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations. No longer will there be anything accursed, but the throne of God and of the Lamb will be in it, and his servants will worship him. They will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads. And night will be no more. They will need no light of lamp or sun, for the Lord God will be their light, and they will reign forever and ever.” The tree of life, lost in Genesis 3, is restored. The river of Eden, now from the throne. And the greatest promise: “They will see his face.” This is the beatific vision, which no one could have and live (Exodus 33:20). Because of Christ, we will see God’s face, and we will reign with him.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:1-2:25 and 3:22-24 are the beginning that Revelation completes. Isaiah 65:17-25 and 66:22 promise new heavens and a new earth. Ezekiel 37:26-28 and 47:1-12 describe God dwelling with his people and a river from the temple. Leviticus 26:11-12 and 2 Corinthians 6:16 repeat the covenant formula. Isaiah 25:8 and 35:10 promise no more tears. Isaiah 60:1-3, 19-20 pictures nations coming to the light. 1 Kings 6:20 describes the cube-shaped Most Holy Place. Ephesians 2:19-22 and Galatians 4:26 speak of the heavenly Jerusalem. Psalm 17:15 and 1 John 3:2 speak of seeing God. Matthew 5:8 promises the pure in heart will see God.

STEP 6

Application

Read the memory verse (21:3-4) aloud, slowly. Which promise most touches your situation today: no more tears, no more death, no more pain?

Imagine the tree of life and the river. How would knowing that this is where history is headed shape the way you spend the day?

Think of someone who is grieving. Share verse 4 with them, and sit with them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he will dwell with his people and wipe away every tear.

Tell him what tears you are bringing him.

Ask him to give you hope for the new creation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 128

“He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen.”

REVELATION 22:20-21

DAY 894 · WEEK 128

Revelation 21:1-22:5; Isaiah 65:17-25; 2 Peter 3:10-13

The New Heavens and New Earth

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 21:1-22:5, Isaiah 65:17-25, and 2 Peter 3:10-13. Today is a doctrinal pause on the new heavens and new earth: the final destiny of believers and of creation. Notice how the Old Testament prophecy, Peter's teaching, and John's vision fit together.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

What is heaven like? Many Christians imagine the final state as a spiritual realm where disembodied souls float on clouds, but the Bible's picture is richer and more physical. The final hope of the believer is not escaping the world but a renewed world, with resurrected bodies in a restored creation, in which God dwells with his people. Getting this right shapes how we value creation, work, and our present life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For behold, I create new heavens and a new earth, and the former things shall not be remembered or come into mind" (Isaiah 65:17).
2. "They shall build houses and inhabit them; they shall plant vineyards and eat their fruit" (Isaiah 65:21).
3. "The wolf and the lamb shall graze together" (Isaiah 65:25).
4. "The day of the Lord will come like a thief" (2 Peter 3:10).
5. "But according to his promise we are waiting for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells" (2 Peter 3:13).
6. "Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth" (Revelation 21:1).

7. “Behold, I am making all things new” (Revelation 21:5).
8. “The throne of God and of the Lamb will be in it, and his servants will worship him” (Revelation 22:3).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Bible’s final hope is the new heavens and new earth. Four features stand out.

First, it is a renewed creation, not a mere escape. God created the world and called it very good. The fall corrupted it, but God does not abandon his creation. Paul says that “the creation itself will be set free from its bondage to corruption and obtain the freedom of the glory of the children of God” (Romans 8:21). Christ’s death and resurrection are the first fruits of the renewal of all things (Colossians 1:20). Christians differ on how much continuity there is between the present creation and the new one. Many Reformed teachers hold that the new earth will be a purification and renewal of this one (as the flood cleansed but did not destroy the earth), while some, including many Lutherans, hold that God will annihilate the present world and create a wholly new one. In either case, the new creation is physical, real, and glorious, and what we do now in faith is not in vain (1 Corinthians 15:58).

Second, it includes the resurrection of the body. We will not be disembodied spirits. When Christ returns, the dead in Christ will be raised, and the living changed, so that we have glorified bodies like his (Philippians 3:20-21; 1 Corinthians 15:42-54). Those who die before then are “with Christ, which is far better” (Philippians 1:23) in a conscious intermediate state, as we saw in Unit 21, but the final hope is resurrection on the new earth.

Third, it is the fulfillment of the covenants. In Genesis 1-2, God made humanity to dwell with him in a garden and to rule creation. Abraham was promised land, and Paul says he was promised “the world” (Romans 4:13). The Israelites who longed for the promised land were looking toward “a better country, that is, a heavenly one” (Hebrews 11:16), “the city that has foundations” (Hebrews 11:10). David’s throne is fulfilled in the reign of Christ. The new covenant, with its promise of forgiveness and God dwelling with his people, comes to its full fruition. In progressive covenantalism, all the covenants find their fulfillment in Christ and his people in the new creation: the land becomes the whole earth, the temple becomes God’s presence with all, and the people of God are drawn from all nations.

Fourth, it is a place of worship, rest, work, and joy. The picture includes seeing God’s face (Revelation 22:4), the absence of sin, death, and tears, the reign of the saints with Christ (22:5), the healing of the nations, and the glory of the nations being brought in (21:24-26). Isaiah 65 includes houses, vineyards, and long life, which suggests meaningful work and

enjoyment, without frustration. There will be rest, as the Sabbath points forward (Hebrews 4:9-11). The center of it all is God himself. As the old catechism says, our chief end is to glorify God and enjoy him forever.

So how should this hope shape us? It gives us courage in suffering (Romans 8:18), motivates holy living (2 Peter 3:11-14), directs our affections toward the things above (Colossians 3:1-4), and prompts us to care for the creation that God will renew. It gives dignity to the work we do now. And it fills us with longing: "Come, Lord Jesus!"

STEP 4

Interpretation

Isaiah 65 is the Old Testament source. God promises new heavens and a new earth, and Jerusalem as a joy. The former things will be forgotten. There will be no more weeping, no more infant mortality, and people will live long. They will build houses and inhabit them, plant vineyards and eat their fruit, no longer for others to take. The wolf and the lamb will graze together; the lion shall eat straw like the ox, and "they shall not hurt or destroy in all my holy mountain." This is a picture of peace, justice, and flourishing. John in Revelation 21 sees the fulfillment on a larger scale.

Peter, in 2 Peter 3, addresses scoffers who say that all things continue as they were. He declares that the day of the Lord will come like a thief, with the heavens passing away with a roar, and the elements dissolved with heat. As we saw on Day 852, this can be read as the purging of the creation by fire. And then the application: "Since all these things are thus to be dissolved, what sort of people ought you to be in lives of holiness and godliness, waiting for and hastening the coming of the day of God?" The hope is the incentive to holiness.

Taken together, these passages show that Christians are not waiting for evacuation but for new creation. Paul's, Peter's, Isaiah's, and John's visions harmonize: the world will be made right, and God will dwell here with his people.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:31, 3:17-19, and Romans 8:18-25 trace creation, fall, and redemption. Colossians 1:15-20 and Ephesians 1:9-10 speak of reconciling all things in Christ. Matthew 19:28 mentions the renewal of all things. Acts 3:21 speaks of the restoration of all things. Philippians 3:20-21 and 1 Corinthians 15:35-58 speak of resurrection bodies. Psalm 37:11 and Matthew 5:5 promise the meek will inherit the earth. Hebrews 11:8-16 and Romans 4:13 speak of the promised world. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 describes Christ's return. Habakkuk 2:14 and Isaiah 11:6-9 describe the earth filled with the knowledge of the LORD.

STEP 6

Application

Think about what you imagined heaven would be like. How does the picture of a renewed earth change it?

Choose one way to care for God's creation this week (a neighbor's yard, a garden, a recycling habit, a walk), as an expression of hope.

Do some of your normal work today as something that will not be wasted in God's new world.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the promise of new heavens and a new earth.

Ask him to help you live as a citizen of that world now.

Tell him what you long for there.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 128

"He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen."

REVELATION 22:20-21

DAY 895 · WEEK 128

Revelation 22:6-21

Come, Lord Jesus, the final words of Scripture

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 16 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Revelation 22:6-21. These are the final words of the Bible. Notice how Jesus speaks directly, repeating "I am coming soon," and how the book ends with an invitation and a prayer.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The visions are over. The angel confirms that "these words are trustworthy and true." What follows is a series of closing statements, partly from the angel, partly from Jesus, partly from John, that function as an epilogue. They return to the themes of the beginning: blessing for those who keep the words, the identity of Christ as Alpha and Omega, the coming of Jesus, and grace. The Bible ends not with a doctrine but with a prayer: "Come, Lord Jesus!"

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And behold, I am coming soon. Blessed is the one who keeps the words of the prophecy of this book" (v. 7).
2. "Behold, I am coming soon, bringing my recompense with me" (v. 12).
3. "I am the Alpha and the Omega, the first and the last, the beginning and the end" (v. 13).
4. "Blessed are those who wash their robes, so that they may have the right to the tree of life" (v. 14).
5. "I am the root and the descendant of David, the bright morning star" (v. 16).
6. "The Spirit and the Bride say, Come. And let the one who hears say, Come" (v. 17).
7. "Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!" (v. 20).
8. "The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen" (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The angel says, “These words are trustworthy and true. And the Lord, the God of the spirits of the prophets, has sent his angel to show his servants what must soon take place.” Then Jesus speaks: “And behold, I am coming soon. Blessed is the one who keeps the words of the prophecy of this book.” This is the sixth of seven blessings. John falls to worship the angel again, and again is told, “You must not do that! I am a fellow servant… Worship God.” Even at the climax of the revelation, only God deserves worship. And John is told, “Do not seal up the words of the prophecy of this book, for the time is near.” The message is not meant to be hidden but to be lived in the present. “Let the evildoer still do evil, and the filthy still be filthy, and the righteous still do right, and the holy still be holy.” The time to respond is now.

Then Jesus speaks again: “Behold, I am coming soon, bringing my recompense with me, to repay each one for what he has done. I am the Alpha and the Omega, the first and the last, the beginning and the end.” He claims the titles of God. Then the last of the seven blessings: “Blessed are those who wash their robes, so that they may have the right to the tree of life and that they may enter the city by the gates.” Outside are the dogs, sorcerers, sexually immoral, murderers, idolaters, and everyone who loves and practices falsehood. Recall 7:14: robes are washed in the blood of the Lamb. This is grace, not merit.

Jesus gives his credentials: “I, Jesus, have sent my angel to testify to you about these things for the churches. I am the root and the descendant of David, the bright morning star.” He is the fulfillment of the promises to David and the herald of a new day (2 Peter 1:19). Then the Spirit and the Bride (the church) say, “Come.” This is the church’s prayer for the return of the Lord, and perhaps also an invitation to those who have not yet believed. “And let the one who hears say, Come. And let the one who is thirsty come; let the one who desires take the water of life without price.” The last invitation of the Bible is an open one. Anyone who is thirsty can come and drink freely.

A warning follows, which has often been applied to the whole Bible: “If anyone adds to them, God will add to him the plagues described in this book, and if anyone takes away from the words of the book of this prophecy, God will take away his share in the tree of life and in the holy city.” It applies first to this book, and by extension to all of God’s word. We are to receive it as it is, neither adding nor subtracting.

The last words belong to Jesus and to John. “He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon.” And John answers: “Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!” The Aramaic form of this prayer, Maranatha, was a cry of the earliest church (1 Corinthians 16:22). The Bible, which began with “In the beginning, God,” ends with grace: “The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen.” The story that began in a garden ends in a city, but throughout, it is the story of the grace of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 1:1-3 parallels the opening. Revelation 7:14 and 22:14 speak of washing robes. Isaiah 55:1 and John 7:37-38 invite the thirsty. Numbers 24:17 and 2 Peter 1:19 mention the star. Isaiah 11:1, 10 speaks of the root of Jesse. Deuteronomy 4:2 and 12:32 warn against adding to or taking from God's word. 1 Corinthians 16:22 contains the prayer Maranatha. Matthew 24:42-44 and 25:13 call us to watchfulness. Titus 2:13 speaks of waiting for the blessed hope. John 14:3 and Acts 1:11 promise Christ's return. 2 Timothy 4:8 speaks of loving his appearing. Genesis 1:1 begins the story.

STEP 6

Application

Make Day 895's final prayer part of your daily rhythm: "Come, Lord Jesus." Say it at the end of the day.

If you are thirsty, accept the invitation of verse 17. If someone you know is thirsty, extend it to them.

Re-commit to receive the Bible as God's complete word, neither adding to it nor taking from it, and to keep reading it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship Jesus as the Alpha and the Omega.
- Pray, "Come, Lord Jesus," and tell him what you want when he comes.
- Ask him to keep you faithful to his word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 128

"He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen."

REVELATION 22:20-21

DAY 896 · WEEK 128

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Revelation 22:20-21 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen."

REVELATION 22:20-21

REST

Meditation

These are the last words of the Bible, and they are a prayer. After sixty-six books, after every promise, warning, and story, the book ends with a longing: "Come, Lord Jesus!"

The words belong to Jesus first: "Surely I am coming soon." He promises. And then the church answers: "Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!" We do not just wait; we long. This is not a nervous prayer but the prayer of a bride for her husband.

And then, a benediction: "The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all." The Bible, which opens with creation, ends with grace. We have no claim on God but this: the unearned favor of the Lord Jesus. Everything depends on it.

Pray these words today, and let your longing for his return increase. Come, Lord Jesus.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you reached the climax of Revelation. Chapters 17 and 18 showed the fall of Babylon, the world system drunk with the blood of the saints, and the call to come out of her. Chapter 19 gave the marriage supper of the Lamb and the rider on the white horse, Faithful and True, with the word of God as his sword. Chapter 20 showed Satan bound, the thousand years (understood in three main ways), and the great white throne. On Day 892, we paused on the final judgment, in which Christ judges with justice, and those in him are not condemned. Chapters 21 and 22 showed the new heavens and new earth, with God dwelling with his people, no more tears, the tree of life, the river, and the sight of his face. On Day 894, we paused on the hope of a renewed creation. And Revelation 22:6-21 gave the final words of the Bible: Jesus is coming soon, the thirsty may take the water of life, and the church prays, "Come, Lord Jesus."

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Revelation 18 shows Babylon's wealth built partly on trafficking in human lives. What do you see in your own culture or economy that resembles this, and what is one concrete thing you can do about it?

Revelation 21:3-4 promises God's dwelling with us, no more tears, and no more death. Which of these promises means the most to you today, and who in your life needs to hear it?

The Bible ends with the prayer, "Come, Lord Jesus!" Do you pray this, and mean it? What are the things that make you hold on to this world, and what would it look like to long for his coming more?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for rest and for the hope of his return.

Pray, "Come, Lord Jesus."

Ask him to prepare you.

DAY 897 · WEEK 129

Psalm 72:18-19

Blessed be the LORD; his glory fills the earth

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 2 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 72 in full, giving special attention to the closing doxology in verses 18 and 19. This is a prayer for the king, and it closes the second book of the Psalter. Notice how a prayer for a human king grows into a prayer for the whole earth to be filled with God's glory.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 72 is a psalm "of Solomon," or perhaps for Solomon, a prayer that the king would rule with God's justice and bring blessing to the nations. It ends Book II of the Psalter with a doxology (vv. 18-19) and a note: "The prayers of David, the son of Jesse, are ended." The psalm describes a king far greater than any Israel ever had: one whose reign extends from sea to sea, whose name endures forever, and through whom all nations are blessed. This is the promise to Abraham (Genesis 12:3) and to David (2 Samuel 7), and the New Testament sees its fulfillment in Jesus. In Revelation, kings do bring their glory into the city (21:24), and the whole earth is filled with the glory of the Lord.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give the king your justice, O God, and your righteousness to the royal son!" (v. 1).
2. "May he defend the cause of the poor of the people, give deliverance to the children of the needy, and crush the oppressor!" (v. 4).
3. "May he have dominion from sea to sea, and from the River to the ends of the earth!" (v. 8).
4. "May all kings fall down before him, all nations serve him!" (v. 11).
5. "May people be blessed in him, all nations call him blessed!" (v. 17).

6. “Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, who alone does wondrous things” (v. 18).
7. “Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!” (v. 19).
8. “The prayers of David, the son of Jesse, are ended” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins as a prayer for the king: “Give the king your justice, O God, and your righteousness to the royal son!” The test of a good king is whether he rules with God’s justice. Specifically, “May he defend the cause of the poor of the people, give deliverance to the children of the needy, and crush the oppressor!” The poor are the king’s first concern. Justice for the vulnerable is central to a godly government and to the reign of Christ.

The prayer then pictures a reign of peace and abundance: “May the mountains bear prosperity for the people, and the hills, in righteousness!” The king will be like rain on mown grass, like showers that water the earth. “In his days may the righteous flourish, and peace abound, till the moon be no more!” His rule extends “from sea to sea, and from the River to the ends of the earth.” Foreign kings bring tribute: “May the kings of Tarshish and of the isles render him tribute; may the kings of Sheba and Seba bring gifts! May all kings fall down before him, all nations serve him!” This echoes the gifts of the wise men to the infant Christ and the vision of the nations bringing their glory into the New Jerusalem. The reason is again compassion: “For he delivers the needy when he calls, the poor and him who has no helper. He has pity on the weak and the needy, and saves the lives of the needy.” He redeems their lives from oppression and violence, and “precious is their blood in his sight.”

The prayer reaches its high point in verse 17: “May his name endure forever, his fame continue as long as the sun! May people be blessed in him, all nations call him blessed!” This is an echo of the Abrahamic promise: “in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed” (Genesis 12:3). No merely human king could fulfill this. Solomon’s reign had a golden beginning but ended in compromise, and the kings after him fell. The psalm remained a prayer for a king who would fulfill it. Jesus is that King. He defends the poor, saves the needy, and brings blessing to all nations. “Behold, something greater than Solomon is here” (Matthew 12:42).

The psalm ends with a doxology that closes Book II: “Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, who alone does wondrous things. Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!” The prayer for the king becomes a prayer for God’s glory over the whole earth. This is the goal of everything: not the king’s honor but the glory of God. The doxology answers Numbers 14:21 and anticipates Habakkuk 2:14. And then the note, “The prayers of David, the son of Jesse, are ended.” The prayers of a man end, but the

prayer for God's kingdom goes on in the prayer Jesus taught us: "Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven." It will be answered fully in the new creation, when the whole earth is filled with his glory.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Samuel 7:12-16 and Genesis 12:1-3 are the promises behind the psalm. 1 Kings 3-10 shows Solomon's reign. Matthew 2:1-12 shows kings bringing gifts to Jesus. Matthew 12:42 and Luke 1:32-33 declare Jesus greater than Solomon. Isaiah 11:1-9 and 9:6-7 describe the righteous king. Numbers 14:21 and Habakkuk 2:14 speak of the earth filled with God's glory. Matthew 6:10 is the prayer for his kingdom to come. Psalm 41:13, 89:52, and 106:48 are the other doxologies closing the books of the Psalter. Revelation 5:9-14, 11:15, and 21:24-26 show the nations and kings worshiping.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Matthew 6:10 slowly: your kingdom come, your will be done. Name one place where you long to see his justice.

Ask how you can "defend the cause of the poor" in a practical way this month through your time, giving, or voice.

End your day with verse 19: "Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!"

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bless the LORD who alone does wondrous things.
- Thank him for the true King, Jesus.
- Ask him to fill the earth with his glory.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 129

“For all the promises of God find their Yes in him. That is why it is through him that we utter our Amen to God for his glory.”

2 CORINTHIANS 1:20

DAY 898 · WEEK 129

Psalm 150

Let everything that has breath praise the LORD, Amen

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 150 again, slowly and aloud. You first met it as trumpets in Revelation 8 to 11. Now read it as the last psalm of the Psalter, the last chapter of your journey, and a summary of what the whole Bible is for.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second time in this unit that we read Psalm 150, and we are glad to return to it. The first time, it prepared us for the trumpets of judgment, and the last time, it is a closing word: the whole Psalter, with all its tears and joys, ends in praise. The same is true of the Bible's whole story. After every lament, every warning, and every war, the last word is "Hallelujah." In Revelation, the word "Hallelujah" (which means "Praise the LORD") appears in 19:1-6, the only place in the New Testament where it is found.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Praise God in his sanctuary" (v. 1).
2. "Praise him in his mighty heavens!" (v. 1).
3. "Praise him according to his excellent greatness!" (v. 2).
4. "Praise him with lute and harp!" (v. 3).
5. "Praise him with strings and pipe!" (v. 4).
6. "Praise him with loud clashing cymbals!" (v. 5).
7. "Let everything that has breath praise the LORD!" (v. 6).
8. "Praise the LORD!" (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The whole book of Psalms is a conversation between God's people and God. It contains songs of trust and complaint, history and prophecy, kings and exiles. Its structure follows a path. The first Psalm begins with the blessed man who delights in God's law, and the book ends with the entire creation breathing praise. It begins with a person and ends with the cosmos. It begins with study and ends with song.

The five verses of the psalm are a final summary of all the praise of the Psalter. Praise is to be given in "his sanctuary" and in "his mighty heavens"; in the earthly place of worship and in the heavenly one. We praise him "for his mighty deeds," a summary of what he has done in creation, the exodus, the covenant, the exile and return, and finally in Christ. We praise him "according to his excellent greatness," because who he is exceeds anything we can say. The music is all the instruments of Israel's worship. Whether we have a trained voice or a tin ear, we can join the praise. And then the invitation to everyone: "Let everything that has breath praise the LORD!" The Hebrew word for breath (neshamah) is the word used in Genesis 2:7, when God breathed into Adam the breath of life. Every breath is a gift, and every breath is an invitation to praise.

Now we read it as the end of a journey. For 900 days, we have traveled through the story of God, from creation to new creation. We have seen the creation, the fall, the call of Abraham, the exodus, the law, the kings, the exile, the return, the coming of Christ, the cross, the resurrection, the birth of the church, the letters to the churches, and the vision of the end. In all of it, we have seen a God who keeps his covenant. The story ends not in despair but in praise. And the psalm that ends the Psalter is a template for the end of our lives: whatever our circumstances, we end in praise. And in Revelation 19, the multitude shouts "Hallelujah" four times. This is the sound of the new creation, and we can begin practicing it now.

"Let everything that has breath praise the LORD! Praise the LORD!" In the Hebrew, the last word of the Psalter is Hallelujah. Say it with the church of every age. Hallelujah.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 2:7 mentions the breath of life. Psalm 1 is the opening of the Psalter. Psalm 145-149 are the other closing psalms of praise. Revelation 19:1-6 has the four Hallelujahs of the great multitude. Revelation 5:11-14 shows the whole creation praising. Ephesians 5:18-20 and Colossians 3:16-17 call for praise in the church. Hebrews 13:15 says to continually offer a sacrifice of praise. Philippians 2:10-11 sees every tongue confessing. Isaiah 43:21 says God

formed his people to declare his praise. 1 Peter 2:9 says we are called to proclaim his excellencies. Romans 11:36 gives a doxology: from him and through him and to him are all things.

STEP 6

Application

Take a moment to look back at what God has done in your life over these years. Name three things that stand out, and thank him.

Sing or speak Psalm 150 aloud, and finish with a loud "Hallelujah."

Let each breath today be a reminder that you were made to praise the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise the LORD in your own words, for his mighty deeds.
- Thank him for what he has done over these days.
- Let everything that has breath praise him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 129

"For all the promises of God find their Yes in him. That is why it is through him that we utter our Amen to God for his glory."

2 CORINTHIANS 1:20

DAY 899 · WEEK 129

Review and Reflection

Unit 25 review, The New Covenant Consummated, Revelation

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God. He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away."
>
> REVELATION 21:3-4

REST

Meditation

This is the memory verse for the final unit, and the destination of the whole Bible. Notice how it begins: "Behold." It is a call to look. After all of history, John is told to look at what God has done.

"The dwelling place of God is with man." The Hebrew Scriptures speak of God's tabernacle, the glory in the temple, and the promise "I will be their God, and they shall be my people." The story began in a garden, where God walked with Adam and Eve. Sin separated us. Christ came, "and the Word became flesh and dwelt among us" (John 1:14). And now God dwells with us forever.

Then the promise: "He will wipe away every tear." God personally wipes tears. It is the picture of a tender Father. "Death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away." Every grief that you carry will be answered.

Say this verse to yourself in the hardest moments, and say it to someone who is grieving. It is not wishful thinking. It is a promise from the one who said, "Behold, I am making all things new."

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

This final unit took us through the book of Revelation, in which all of God's covenant promises find their Yes in Christ. In chapters 1 to 3, we saw the risen Christ among his churches, and his letters calling them to love, faithfulness, and repentance. In chapters 4 and 5, we entered the throne room, where the Lion of Judah is a Lamb who was slain, worthy to open the scroll of history. The seals, trumpets, and bowls showed God's judgment on a rebellious world and the church's call to endure, with the sealed multitude from every nation. Chapters 12 and 13 unmasked the dragon and the beasts, and showed that the saints conquer by the blood of the Lamb, by the word of their testimony, and by not loving their lives even unto death. Chapters 17 to 20 showed the fall of Babylon, the marriage supper of the Lamb, Christ's return, the defeat of Satan, and the final judgment. Chapters 21 and 22 revealed the new heavens and new earth, with God dwelling with his people, the river and tree of life, and the final invitation, "Come." Psalms 1, 19, 29, 141, 150, 148, 2, 46, 93, 97, and 72 provided songs along the way: the two ways, creation and word, the voice of the LORD, prayers as incense, praise, and the reign of God. The doctrinal pauses covered the final judgment and the new creation.

REFLECT

Review Questions

How does Revelation draw on imagery from every major section of the Old Testament?

Choose two images from Revelation (for example, the tree of life, the plagues, or the temple) and trace where they come from in the Old Testament.

What does it mean that the Lamb who was slain holds the scroll of history?

In your own words, explain how Christ's death is the key to history, and how this might change the way you see current events.

How do Revelation 21 and 22 fulfill the promises of Genesis 1 and 2?

List three things from the Garden of Eden that return in the new creation, and say what each tells you about God's purpose.

Looking back: where do you see God's covenant faithfulness from beginning to end?

Name three moments in the Bible's story where God kept his promises, and one moment in your own life where you have seen his faithfulness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he will dwell with you and wipe away every tear.

Tell him what you have seen of the Lamb in Revelation.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

DAY 900 · WEEK 129

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

This is the last day of the plan. There is no new reading today. Read 2 Corinthians 1:20 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the look back below, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For all the promises of God find their Yes in him. That is why it is through him that we utter our Amen to God for his glory."

2 CORINTHIANS 1:20

REST

Meditation

You have made it to the end of 900 days. That is a remarkable thing, and God gets the glory. Whether you read every day or caught up after missing weeks, you have been through the whole Bible and the heart of the Christian faith.

This verse is a good summary of what you have read. "All the promises of God find their Yes in him." In Genesis, God promised a seed who would crush the serpent. He promised Abraham a blessing for all nations. He promised David a son who would reign forever. He promised a new covenant, forgiveness, a new heart, his Spirit, and a new creation. Every promise, big or small, finds its Yes in Jesus Christ.

"That is why it is through him that we utter our Amen to God for his glory." Because the promises are fulfilled in Christ, we can say "Amen," meaning "so be it, we trust you," to everything God says. The Bible began with God speaking and ends with the church saying

“Amen.”

You do not finish the Bible; it keeps reading you. This is a place to begin, not an end. Where do you go from here? Keep reading, and read the Bible again, now that you know the story. Pick a book and read it slowly, with a study Bible or commentary. Stay rooted in a local church, where you can hear the word preached, receive the Lord’s Supper, and be loved and corrected. Pray the Psalms. Memorize Scripture. Teach someone else what you have learned. Start again at Day 1 with a friend. And hold on to Christ: he is the Yes to every promise, and he will hold on to you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This final stretch of the plan took you from the fall of Babylon to the new Jerusalem. You read of the marriage supper of the Lamb, the rider on the white horse, the binding of Satan, the great white throne, the new heavens and new earth, and the last words of the Bible: “Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!” Psalm 72 prayed for the true King through whom all nations will be blessed, and Psalm 150 ended the Psalter with praise. Day 899 reviewed the whole of Revelation. And now you have finished the whole plan: the story of creation, fall, redemption, and new creation, told across the Old Testament, the Gospels, Acts, the letters, and Revelation, with the key doctrines of the Christian faith along the way. From Genesis 1:1 to Revelation 22:21, the Bible tells one story, whose center is Jesus Christ. God has been faithful from beginning to end.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Looking back over the 900 days, what is one truth about God that you understand better now than when you began? How has it changed the way you pray, live, or think?

Paul says that all the promises of God find their Yes in Christ. Which promise, from anywhere in the Bible, has become most precious to you, and how do you see it fulfilled in Jesus?

What is one concrete step you will take in the next month to keep growing: a reading habit, a church community, a person to disciple or be discipled by? Write it down and tell someone.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for these 900 days in his word, naming something he has done in you.

Thank him that every promise finds its yes in Jesus.

Ask him to keep you reading, praying, and following for the rest of your life.

Catechism.

APPENDIX I

Companion Reference

A Bible Reading Plan for New Believers

A guide to using the plan, an author's note, memory verses, a guide to the Psalms, a weekly checklist, and a glossary.

Contents

1 **How to Use This Plan**
A short guide for new readers

2 **An Author's Note**
Where this plan comes from

3 **The Plan at a Glance**
All 25 units

4 **Memory Verses in Order**
Every Sabbath verse and unit verse

5 **Doctrinal Pauses**
The 44 teaching days

6 **The Psalms in This Plan**
Why one day in four is a psalm

7 **Weekly Checklist**
All 129 weeks, Sunday through Saturday

8 **Glossary**
Key terms used in the plan

START HERE

How to Use This Plan

A short guide for new readers

❦

This plan walks you through the whole Bible in 900 days, about two and a half years, and stops along the way to teach you the main beliefs of the Christian faith and how to study Scripture for yourself. You do not need any background. You need a Bible, a quiet fifteen to twenty-five minutes, and a willingness to keep coming back.

The Shape of the Plan

The plan has two halves. Year 1, Promise and Shadow, covers Units 1 to 14 and follows the story from creation through the Old Testament and the promises God makes. Year 2, Fulfillment, covers Units 15 to 25 and follows Jesus, the church, and the hope of the new creation. Each unit has its own document with a title page, a contents list, and one entry for every day.

Weeks run from Sunday to Saturday. Six days of reading are followed by a Sabbath rest on Saturday, so every seventh day is lighter. The Weekly Checklist in this appendix lists all 129 weeks so you can see where you are and mark your progress.

A Normal Day

Each reading day follows the same pattern, so you always know what to expect.

- Reading: the passage for the day. Read it slowly, and aloud if you can.
- Setting the Scene: who wrote this, who it was written to, and what is going on.
- Observation: questions that help you notice what the text actually says.
- Interpretation: what the passage means in its own setting.
- Connection: how the passage points to Jesus and fits the whole Bible.
- Application: what to believe, change, or do in response.
- Prayer: two or three prompts to help you respond to God in your own words. The week's memory verse closes each day as a reminder.

Read the passage first, then the guide. If you have more time, read the passage twice before you open the commentary. The guide is there to help you see the text, not to replace it.

Special Days

Sabbath days come every Saturday. You do not read a new passage. You meditate on the memory verse, look back over the week, and answer three reflection questions, the middle one always about Christ. Treat the day as rest, not catch-up.

Doctrinal pauses interrupt the story to study one teaching of the faith, such as the Trinity or justification. They carry an extra section called the Doctrinal Focus. Appendix I lists all 44.

Unit reviews close each unit. They recap what you learned, bring back the unit anchor verse, and ask questions that help it stick. Three reviews fall on a Saturday and combine the review with the Sabbath.

Memory Verses

Each unit has one anchor verse. You do not have to memorize it perfectly. Read it each Saturday, say it aloud a few times, and let it settle. All 25 are listed in Appendix I, together with each week's Sabbath verse.

If You Fall Behind

You will. Everyone does. Do not try to read three days at once. Pick up at the next day and keep going. The checklist is a record, not a grade. If you miss a Sabbath, skip it and move on. If you miss a long stretch, start again at the beginning of the current unit and read at a gentler pace. A plan you finish slowly is better than one you abandon.

Studying the Bible on Your Own

The daily guides use a simple three-part method you can use anywhere in the Bible.

- Observe: what does the text say? Note who, what, where, when, and the words that repeat.
- Interpret: what did it mean to its first readers? Read the verses around it before you decide.
- Apply: what does it call me to believe, love, or do?

Add one more question every time: where is Christ in this passage? Jesus taught that the whole Bible speaks of him (Luke 24:27). The question will not always have a quick answer, but asking it will change how you read.

Reading With Others

This plan works well in a small group, a family, or with one friend. Agree on a day each week, usually the Sabbath, to talk about the week. Share one thing you noticed, one thing you did not understand, and one way you will respond. Write your questions down. Bring the hard ones to a pastor or a mature Christian. Confusion is a normal part of learning.

Bible Translation

The guides quote and refer to the English Standard Version (ESV), but any faithful translation will work. They give references and brief quotations, but they do not print the full passage, so keep your Bible open.

What Else Is in This Appendix

- An Author's Note: where the plan comes from and where its author stands.
- The Plan at a Glance: every unit with its days and weeks.
- Memory Verses in Order: every Sabbath verse and unit verse, in the order you meet them.
- Doctrinal Pauses: an index of the 44 teaching days.
- The Psalms in This Plan: why the Psalms are woven through all 900 days.
- Weekly Checklist: all 129 weeks, Sunday to Saturday.
- Glossary: short definitions of the key terms used in the plan.

START HERE

An Author's Note

Where this plan comes from, and what you should know before you trust it

❦

This plan is meant for a person in the first years of following Jesus. It walks through the whole Bible in 900 days, stops now and then to teach the beliefs of the Christian faith, and tries to show you how to read Scripture for yourself. I've called it Catechism. A catechism is a tool for teaching new believers what Christians believe, and that is the job I hope this plan does.

Where I Am Coming From

I believe the Bible is the word of God, true and trustworthy from beginning to end. I believe in one God in three persons, in the full deity and full humanity of Jesus, in his death in the place of sinners and his bodily resurrection, and in salvation by grace alone through faith alone in Christ alone. My reading of Scripture leans toward the sovereignty of God in salvation and the sufficiency of Christ, and I do not want to hide that.

The framework behind the plan is what some call progressive covenantalism. Big terms like that can sometimes overcomplicate things, but I think the idea is fairly simple. The Bible tells one story, and God tells it through a series of covenants: with creation and Adam, with Noah, with Abraham, with Israel at Sinai, with David, and finally the new covenant in Christ. Each covenant builds on the one before it and points ahead to the next. Jesus fulfills them all.

That idea explains the shape of the plan. Year 1, Promise and Shadow, moves through the covenants one at a time. Year 2, Fulfillment, follows Jesus, the church, and the new creation. Many of the units carry the names of covenants. The Connection section of a daily guide asks how a passage leads to Christ. The middle question on each Sabbath day is always about him. These are choices that come straight from the framework.

Not every Christian reads the Bible this way. Some hold that God has one covenant of grace unfolding through history, with Israel and the church closely joined. Others distinguish sharply between God's purposes for Israel and for the church. Those traditions have produced faithful, Bible-loving people, and they will sometimes read a passage differently than I do. Where it matters I have tried to say so. Where I have not, you may need to notice it yourself.

I have also tried to avoid the private vocabulary of any one camp. The goal is accessible depth: enough substance to feed a growing believer, without requiring you to join a side before you can read a page. My hope is that through this plan, you will feel equipped to open your Bible and know what to do next. God's Word is living, and I want you to love it, learn it, and live by it.

Decisions You Should Know About

A plan like this makes hundreds of choices on the reader's behalf. Most are invisible. These are the ones I think you should see.

The story is organized by covenant. The units follow the covenants, not the order of the books in your Bible. That is a way of reading the Bible, not the only way.

The reading order is a decision. The plan is not in canonical order. Job sits between Abraham and the Exodus, following the common view that its setting is patriarchal, though the book does not date itself and scholars differ. The Psalms are woven through the whole plan. The Wisdom books come after David and Solomon. The Gospels are read in the order Matthew, Luke, John, and Mark. Hebrews comes before the General Epistles and Revelation. Other orders are reasonable, and where the date or authorship of a book is debated, the Books of the Bible section of Appendix II says so.

Christ is the center of every part. Jesus taught that the Law, the Prophets, and the Psalms all speak of him (Luke 24:44). I have read the Old Testament that way throughout. Some readers will feel that I find Christ in places where the original author may not have seen him clearly. I have tried to lean on how the New Testament itself reads the Old, and to be modest where it does not.

The doctrinal pauses reflect my judgment. The 44 doctrinal days cover what I think a new believer most needs, plus the teachings the story itself raises. Where Christians have long agreed, I state it plainly. Where faithful Christians differ, I try to describe the positions fairly and say that they differ. I will not always have kept my own view out of it.

The weekly rhythm is built into the calendar. Six days of reading are followed by a day of rest, and the unit boundaries bend around that rhythm. The rest day falls on Saturday only because the plan begins on a Sunday. How Christians should keep the Sabbath or the Lord's Day is a question on which they differ, and the plan does not settle it.

Every guide is a selection. Each daily guide is short, and it leaves out far more than it includes. Choosing what to notice in a passage is already interpretation. Another teacher would choose differently, and the passage is always richer than the guide.

The translation is the English Standard Version. The guides refer to the ESV. Any faithful translation will serve you, and reading in more than one is a good habit.

REFERENCE

The Plan at a Glance

Twenty-five units across about two and a half years

The plan runs 900 days, which is 128 full weeks and a final partial week of four days. Week 1 begins on a Sunday, and every Saturday is a Sabbath rest day. Weeks and days are numbered continuously from the first day.

UNIT	TITLE AND BOOKS	DAYS	WEEKS
YEAR 1: PROMISE AND SHADOW			
1	**Creation and the Covenant of Works** *Genesis 1-3*	1-16	1-3
2	**Common Grace and the Noahic Covenant** *Genesis 4-11*	17-28	3-4
3	**The Abrahamic Covenant** *Genesis 12-50*	29-63	5-9
4	**Job: Suffering and Sovereignty** *Job 1-42*	64-93	10-14
5	**The Mosaic Covenant I: Exodus** *Exodus 1-24*	94-116	14-17
6	**The Mosaic Covenant II: Tabernacle and Holiness** *Exodus 25-40, Leviticus*	117-149	17-22
7	**Wilderness: Numbers and Deuteronomy** *Numbers, Deuteronomy*	150-199	22-29
8	**Conquest and Settlement** *Joshua, Judges, Ruth*	200-234	29-34
9	**The Davidic Covenant** *1-2 Samuel, 1 Kings 1-11, Psalms I-II integrated*	235-301	34-43
10	**Wisdom Literature** *Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Solomon*	302-333	44-48
11	**The Divided Kingdom and Early Prophets** *1 Kings 12-2 Kings 17, Amos, Hosea, Jonah, Micah*	334-378	48-54
12	**Hezekiah, Isaiah and the Assyrian Crisis** *2 Kings 18-20, Isaiah 1-39, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah*	379-420	55-60

13	**Exile: Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel** *Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel*	421-495	61-71
14	**The Return and the Chronicles Perspective** *Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther, Chronicles, Joel, Obadiah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi*	496-564	71-81
YEAR 2: FULFILLMENT			
15	**The New Covenant Inaugurated: Matthew** *Matthew 1-28*	565-602	81-86
16	**The New Covenant Inaugurated: Luke** *Luke 1-24*	603-633	87-91
17	**The New Covenant Inaugurated: John** *John 1-21*	634-665	91-95
18	**The New Covenant Inaugurated: Mark** *Mark 1-16*	666-686	96-98
19	**The New Covenant Applied: Acts** *Acts 1-28*	687-724	99-104
20	**The New Covenant Explained: Romans** *Romans 1-16*	725-752	104-108
21	**Law, Gospel and Church Life: Galatians, Corinthians** *Galatians, 1-2 Corinthians*	753-784	108-112
22	**In Christ: Prison and Pastoral Epistles** *Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, Thessalonians, Pastoral Epistles, Philemon*	785-819	113-117
23	**The Better Covenant: Hebrews** *Hebrews 1-13*	820-836	118-120
24	**Faith Lived Out: General Epistles** *James, 1-2 Peter, 1-3 John, Jude*	837-865	120-124
25	**The New Covenant Consummated: Revelation** *Revelation 1-22*	866-900	124-129

REFERENCE

Memory Verses in Order

Every Sabbath verse and every unit verse, in the order you meet them

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Each Saturday you meditate on one verse. Each unit also has an anchor verse, the "unit verse," which comes back in the unit review. You do not have to memorize them perfectly. Read the verse, say it aloud a few times, and let it settle.

Unit 1: Creation and the Covenant of Works

WEEK 1 · DAY 7
Genesis 1:1 *"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."*

WEEK 2 · DAY 14
Psalm 19:1 *"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 16
Genesis 1:1 *"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."*

Unit 2: Common Grace and the Noahic Covenant

WEEK 3 · DAY 21
Genesis 6:8 *"But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 27
Genesis 6:8 *"But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD."*

WEEK 4 · DAY 28
Genesis 9:13 *"I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth."*

Unit 3: The Abrahamic Covenant

WEEK 5 · DAY 35
Genesis 12:3 *"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."*

WEEK 6 · DAY 42
Genesis 15:6 *"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."*

WEEK 7 · DAY 49
Genesis 28:15 *"Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."*

WEEK 8 · DAY 56
Genesis 39:23 *"The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 62
Genesis 15:6 *"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."*

WEEK 9 · DAY 63
Genesis 50:20 *"You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive."*

Unit 4: Job: Suffering and Sovereignty

WEEK 10 · DAY 70

Job 1:21 *"The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD."*

WEEK 11 · DAY 77

Job 13:15 *"Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face."*

WEEK 12 · DAY 84

Job 28:28 *"Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding."*

WEEK 13 · DAY 91

Job 42:5 *"I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 93

Job 19:25 *"For I know that my Redeemer lives, and at the last he will stand upon the earth."*

Unit 5: The Mosaic Covenant I: Exodus

WEEK 14 · DAY 98

Exodus 3:14 *"God said to Moses, I AM WHO I AM. And he said, Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you."*

WEEK 15 · DAY 105

Exodus 12:13 *"The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you."*

WEEK 16 · DAY 112

Exodus 15:2 *"The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 116

Exodus 20:2 *"I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery."*

Unit 6: The Mosaic Covenant II: Tabernacle and Holiness

WEEK 17 · DAY 119

Exodus 25:8 *"And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst."*

WEEK 18 · DAY 126

Psalm 24:3-4 *"Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."*

WEEK 19 · DAY 133

Leviticus 10:3 *"Among those who are near me I will be sanctified, and before all the people I will be glorified."*

WEEK 20 · DAY 140

Leviticus 19:2 *"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy."*

WEEK 21 · DAY 147

Psalm 91:1 *"He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 149

Leviticus 17:11 *"For the life of the flesh is in the blood, and I have given it for you on the altar to make atonement for your souls, for it is the blood that makes atonement by the life."*

Unit 7: Wilderness: Numbers and Deuteronomy

WEEK 22 · DAY 154

Numbers 6:24-26 *"The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace."*

WEEK 23 · DAY 161

Psalm 95:7-8 *"Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts, as at Meribah, as on the day at Massah in the wilderness."*

WEEK 24 · DAY 168

Psalm 100:3 *"Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture."*

WEEK 25 · DAY 175

Deuteronomy 1:31 *"And in the wilderness, where you saw how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son, all the way that you went until you came to this place."*

WEEK 26 · DAY 182

Deuteronomy 6:6-7 *"And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise."*

WEEK 27 · DAY 189

Deuteronomy 18:15 *"The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among you, from your brothers; it is to him you shall listen."*

WEEK 28 · DAY 196

Deuteronomy 29:29 *"The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may do all the words of this law."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 199

Deuteronomy 6:4-5 *"Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one. You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might."*

Unit 8: Conquest and Settlement

WEEK 29 · DAY 203

Joshua 1:9 *"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."*

WEEK 30 · DAY 210

Psalm 16:5-6 *"The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot. The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance."*

WEEK 31 · DAY 217

Joshua 21:45 *"Not one word of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass."*

WEEK 32 · DAY 224

Zechariah 4:6 *"Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts."*

WEEK 33 · DAY 231

Psalm 130:7 *"O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 234

Joshua 24:15 *"But as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD."*

Unit 9: The Davidic Covenant

WEEK 34 · DAY 238

1 Samuel 2:2 *"There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God."*

WEEK 35 · DAY 245

Psalm 3:3 *"But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head."*

WEEK 36 · DAY 252

1 Samuel 16:7 *"Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart."*

WEEK 37 · DAY 259

Psalm 18:2 *"The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold."*

WEEK 38 · DAY 266

Psalm 20:7 *"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God."*

WEEK 39 · DAY 273

2 Samuel 7:16 *"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."*

WEEK 40 · DAY 280

Psalm 51:10 *"Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."*

WEEK 41 · DAY 287

Psalm 34:8 *"Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!"*

WEEK 42 · DAY 294

Psalm 72:19 *"Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!"*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 301

2 Samuel 7:16 *"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."*

Unit 10: Wisdom Literature

WEEK 44 · DAY 308

Proverbs 1:7 *"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction."*

WEEK 45 · DAY 315

Psalm 119:105 *"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path."*

WEEK 46 · DAY 322

Proverbs 31:30 *"Charm is deceitful, and beauty is vain, but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised."*

WEEK 47 · DAY 329

Ecclesiastes 12:13 *"The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 333

Proverbs 3:5-6 *"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."*

Unit 11: The Divided Kingdom and Early Prophets

WEEK 48 · DAY 336

Proverbs 3:5-6 *"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."*

WEEK 49 · DAY 343

1 Kings 18:39 *"And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God."*

WEEK 50 · DAY 350

2 Kings 6:16 *"Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them."*

WEEK 51 · DAY 357

Amos 5:24 *"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."*

WEEK 52 · DAY 364

Hosea 2:19 *"And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy."*

WEEK 53 · DAY 371

Jonah 2:9 *"But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!"*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 377

Hosea 6:6 *"For I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings."*

WEEK 54 · DAY 378

Micah 6:8 *"He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?"*

Unit 12: Hezekiah, Isaiah and the Assyrian Crisis

WEEK 55 · DAY 385

Isaiah 7:14 *"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel."*

WEEK 56 · DAY 392

Isaiah 9:6 *"For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace."*

WEEK 57 · DAY 399

Isaiah 26:3 *"You keep him in perfect peace whose mind is stayed on you, because he trusts in you."*

WEEK 58 · DAY 406

Isaiah 40:31 *"But they who wait for the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint."*

WEEK 59 · DAY 413

Isaiah 53:5 *"But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 420

Isaiah 6:3 *"Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!"*

Unit 13: Exile: Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel

WEEK 61 · DAY 427

Jeremiah 2:13 *"For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water."*

WEEK 62 · DAY 434

Jeremiah 17:7-8 *"Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD, whose trust is the LORD. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes."*

WEEK 63 · DAY 441

Jeremiah 29:11 *"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope."*

WEEK 64 · DAY 448

Jeremiah 31:3 *"I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness to you."*

WEEK 65 · DAY 455

Jeremiah 33:3 *"Call to me and I will answer you, and will tell you great and hidden things that you have not known."*

WEEK 66 · DAY 462

Lamentations 3:22-23 *"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."*

WEEK 67 · DAY 469

Psalm 73:26 *"My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever."*

WEEK 68 · DAY 476

Ezekiel 18:32 *"For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Lord GOD; so turn, and live."*

WEEK 69 · DAY 483

Ezekiel 36:26 *"And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh."*

WEEK 70 · DAY 490

Daniel 3:17-18 *"If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 495

Jeremiah 31:33 *"I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people."*

Unit 14: The Return and the Chronicles Perspective

WEEK 71 · DAY 497

Ezra 3:11 *"And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel."*

WEEK 72 · DAY 504

Ezra 7:10 *"For Ezra had set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel."*

WEEK 73 · DAY 511

Nehemiah 8:10 *"Do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength."*

WEEK 74 · DAY 518

Esther 4:14 *"And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?"*

WEEK 75 · DAY 525

1 Chronicles 16:34 *"Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!"*

WEEK 76 · DAY 532

1 Chronicles 17:27 *"Now you have been pleased to bless the house of your servant, that it may continue forever before you. For it is you, O LORD, who have blessed, and it is blessed forever."*

WEEK 77 · DAY 539

2 Chronicles 7:14 *"If my people who are called by my name humble themselves, and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and heal their land."*

WEEK 78 · DAY 546

2 Chronicles 16:9 *"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to give strong support to those whose heart is blameless toward him."*

WEEK 79 · DAY 553

Joel 2:13 *"Rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster."*

WEEK 80 · DAY 560

Zechariah 4:6 *"Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 564

Zechariah 9:9 *"Behold, your king is coming to you; righteous and having salvation is he, humble and mounted on a donkey."*

Unit 15: The New Covenant Inaugurated: Matthew

WEEK 81 · DAY 567

Matthew 1:21 *"You shall call his name Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins."*

WEEK 82 · DAY 574

Matthew 5:16 *"In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven."*

WEEK 83 · DAY 581

Matthew 11:28 *"Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest."*

WEEK 84 · DAY 588

Matthew 17:5 *"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."*

WEEK 85 · DAY 595

Matthew 22:37 *"You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 601

Matthew 16:16 *"You are the Christ, the Son of the living God."*

WEEK 86 · DAY 602

Matthew 28:19-20 *"Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age."*

Unit 16: The New Covenant Inaugurated: Luke

WEEK 87 · DAY 609

Luke 2:11 *"For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord."*

WEEK 88 · DAY 616

Luke 9:23 *"If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross daily and follow me."*

WEEK 89 · DAY 623

Luke 15:7 *"Just so, I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance."*

WEEK 90 · DAY 630

Luke 22:19 *"This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 633

Luke 19:10 *"For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost."*

Unit 17: The New Covenant Inaugurated: John

WEEK 91 · DAY 637

John 1:14 *"And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth."*

WEEK 92 · DAY 644

John 4:24 *"God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth."*

WEEK 93 · DAY 651

John 8:12 *"I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."*

WEEK 94 · DAY 658

John 14:6 *"I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 664

John 3:16 *"For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life."*

WEEK 95 · DAY 665

John 20:31 *"But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."*

Unit 18: The New Covenant Inaugurated: Mark

WEEK 96 · DAY 672

Mark 1:15 *"The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel."*

WEEK 97 · DAY 679

Mark 9:23 *"And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 686

Mark 10:45 *"For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."*

Unit 19: The New Covenant Applied: Acts

WEEK 99 · DAY 693

Acts 2:42 *"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers."*

WEEK 100 · DAY 700

Acts 4:12 *"And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved."*

WEEK 101 · DAY 707

Acts 10:43 *"To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."*

WEEK 102 · DAY 714

Acts 16:31 *"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."*

WEEK 103 · DAY 721

Acts 20:24 *"But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 724

Acts 1:8 *"But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."*

Unit 20: The New Covenant Explained: Romans

WEEK 104 · DAY 728

Romans 1:16 *"For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek."*

WEEK 105 · DAY 735

Romans 3:23-24 *"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."*

WEEK 106 · DAY 742

Romans 5:8 *"But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us."*

WEEK 107 · DAY 749

Romans 10:9 *"Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 752

Romans 8:1 *"There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."*

Unit 21: Law, Gospel and Church Life: Galatians, Corinthians

WEEK 108 · DAY 756

Galatians 4:4-5 *"But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons."*

WEEK 109 · DAY 763

1 Corinthians 1:18 *"For the word of the cross is folly to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God."*

WEEK 110 · DAY 770

1 Corinthians 13:13 *"So now faith, hope, and love abide, these three; but the greatest of these is love."*

WEEK 111 · DAY 777

1 Corinthians 15:3-4 *"For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 783

Galatians 2:20 *"I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me."*

WEEK 112 · DAY 784

2 Corinthians 12:9 *"My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness."*

Unit 22: In Christ: Prison and Pastoral Epistles

WEEK 113 · DAY 791

Ephesians 2:8-9 *"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."*

WEEK 114 · DAY 798

Philippians 4:6-7 *"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."*

WEEK 115 · DAY 805

Colossians 3:17 *"And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."*

WEEK 116 · DAY 812

1 Thessalonians 5:16-18 *"Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 818

Colossians 1:15-16 *"He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation. For by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth."*

WEEK 117 · DAY 819

2 Timothy 3:16-17 *"All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work."*

Unit 23: The Better Covenant: Hebrews

WEEK 118 · DAY 826

Hebrews 1:3 *"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."*

WEEK 119 · DAY 833

Hebrews 12:1-2 *"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 836

Hebrews 4:15-16 *"For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but one who in every respect has been tempted as we are, yet without sin. Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace, that we may receive mercy and find grace to help in time of need."*

Unit 24: Faith Lived Out: General Epistles

WEEK 120 · DAY 840

James 1:22 *"But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves."*

WEEK 121 · DAY 847

1 Peter 1:3-4 *"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."*

WEEK 122 · DAY 854

2 Peter 3:18 *"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."*

WEEK 123 · DAY 861

1 John 1:9 *"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 865

1 John 4:19 *"We love because he first loved us."*

Unit 25: The New Covenant Consummated: Revelation

WEEK 124 · DAY 868

Revelation 1:17-18 *"Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades."*

WEEK 125 · DAY 875

Revelation 5:12 *"Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!"*

WEEK 126 · DAY 882

Revelation 12:11 *"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death."*

WEEK 127 · DAY 889

Revelation 15:3-4 *"Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy."*

WEEK 128 · DAY 896

Revelation 22:20-21 *"He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen."*

UNIT VERSE · DAY 899

Revelation 21:3-4 *"Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God. He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away."*

WEEK 129 · DAY 900

2 Corinthians 1:20 *"For all the promises of God find their Yes in him. That is why it is through him that we utter our Amen to God for his glory."*

REFERENCE

Doctrinal Pauses

Days that stop the story to study a teaching of the faith

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On these days the reading has one extra section, the Doctrinal Focus, which sets out what the Bible teaches on a topic and how Christians have understood it.

DAY	UNIT	TOPIC	PASSAGES
2	1	**The Doctrine of Scripture (Bibliology)**	*2 Timothy 3:14-17; 2 Peter 1:16-21*
4	1	**The Image of God**	*Genesis 1:26-28; Genesis 9:6; James 3:9*
6	1	**The Doctrine of Sin (Hamartiology)**	*Genesis 3:1-24; Romans 5:12-21*
32	3	**Covenant Theology, A Framework**	*Genesis 15:1-21; Jeremiah 31:31-34; Hebrews 8:6-13*
86	4	**The Decrees of God and Providence**	*Ephesians 1:11; Romans 11:33-36; Job 42:1-6*
87	4	**Suffering and the Christian Life**	*Romans 8:18-30; 1 Peter 4:12-19; 2 Corinthians 4:7-18*
96	5	**The Existence and Attributes of God**	*Exodus 3:13-15; Exodus 34:5-7*
111	5	**The Moral Law and the Christian**	*Exodus 20:1-17; Matthew 5:17-48; Romans 13:8-10*
184	7	**The Three Offices of Christ, Prophet, Priest, King**	*Deuteronomy 18:15-19; Psalm 110; Hebrews 1:1-4*
386	12	**The Holiness of God**	*Isaiah 6:1-7; 1 Peter 1:14-16*
409	12	**The Work of Christ, Atonement**	*Isaiah 53:1-12; Romans 3:21-26; Hebrews 9:11-28*
571	15	**Prayer**	*Matthew 6:5-15; Luke 11:1-13*
599	15	**The Trinity**	*Deuteronomy 6:4; Matthew 28:18-20; 2 Corinthians 13:14*
600	15	**The Sacraments, Baptism**	*Matthew 28:18-20; Romans 6:1-4; Acts 2:38-41; Colossians 2:11-12*
635	17	**The Person of Christ, Incarnation**	*John 1:1-18; Philippians 2:5-11; Colossians 1:15-20*
638	17	**Regeneration and the New Birth**	*John 3:1-21; Ezekiel 36:25-27; Titus 3:3-7*
642	17	**Worship**	*John 4:19-26; Psalm 95; Hebrews 12:18-29*

667	18	**The Kingdom of God, Already and Not Yet**	*Mark 1:14-15; Luke 17:20-21; 1 Corinthians 15:20-28*
688	19	**The Ascension and Heavenly Session of Christ**	*Acts 1:1-11; Hebrews 4:14-16*
689	19	**The Person and Work of the Holy Spirit**	*John 14:15-31; John 16:5-15; Acts 2:1-21*
690	19	**Repentance**	*Acts 2:37-41; 2 Corinthians 7:8-11*
691	19	**The Means of Grace, Word, Sacrament, Prayer**	*Acts 2:42; Romans 10:14-17*
726	20	**The Wrath of God**	*Romans 1:18-32; Nahum 1:2-8*
730	20	**Justification by Faith Alone**	*Romans 3:21-31; Romans 4:1-8; Galatians 2:15-21*
737	20	**Union with Christ**	*Romans 6:1-14; Galatians 2:20; Ephesians 2:4-10*
740	20	**Sanctification**	*Romans 6:1-14; 1 Thessalonians 4:1-8; Philippians 2:12-13*
754	21	**Adoption**	*Romans 8:14-17; Galatians 4:1-7; 1 John 3:1-3*
765	21	**The Sacraments, The Lord's Supper**	*1 Corinthians 11:17-34; Luke 22:14-20; Matthew 26:26-29*
768	21	**Spiritual Gifts and the Body of Christ**	*1 Corinthians 12:1-31; Romans 12:3-8; Ephesians 4:11-16*
774	21	**The Resurrection of Christ**	*1 Corinthians 15:1-28; Matthew 28:1-10*
775	21	**The Resurrection of the Dead**	*1 Corinthians 15:35-58; Daniel 12:1-3; John 5:28-29*
779	21	**Death and the Intermediate State**	*2 Corinthians 5:1-10; Philippians 1:21-24; Luke 23:39-43*
786	22	**Election and Predestination**	*Ephesians 1:3-14; Romans 9:1-24*
787	22	**The Nature of the Church**	*Matthew 16:13-20; Ephesians 2:11-22; 1 Peter 2:4-10*
795	22	**The Two Natures of Christ, The Hypostatic Union**	*Philippians 2:5-11; Hebrews 2:14-18*
801	22	**The Doctrine of Vocation**	*1 Corinthians 7:17-24; Colossians 3:22-4:1*
803	22	**The Return of Christ**	*1 Thessalonians 4:13-18; Matthew 24:30-31; Revelation 1:7*

811	22	**Church Government and Officers**	*1 Timothy 3:1-13; Titus 1:5-9; Acts 6:1-6*
830	23	**Membership in the Local Church**	*Acts 2:42-47; Hebrews 10:24-25*
839	24	**Saving Faith vs. Mere Belief**	*James 2:14-26; Hebrews 11:1-6*
851	24	**The Canon of Scripture**	*2 Peter 1:16-21; 2 Peter 3:15-16*
860	24	**Perseverance and Assurance**	*John 10:27-30; Romans 8:31-39; 1 John 5:11-13*
892	25	**The Final Judgment**	*Revelation 20:11-15; Matthew 25:31-46; 2 Corinthians 5:10*
894	25	**The New Heavens and New Earth**	*Revelation 21:1-22:5; Isaiah 65:17-25; 2 Peter 3:10-13*

REFERENCE

The Psalms in This Plan

Why one day in four is a psalm, and what each one is doing

Most of the Bible tells you what God has done. The Psalms are where God's people answer him. For that reason the plan does not save the Psalms for one stretch of the calendar. It weaves them through all 900 days, so that after a long run of narrative, law, prophecy, or letter there is a day when you stop reading about people who prayed and pray alongside them.

The Psalms earn that place. They are among the most quoted books of the Old Testament in the New. Jesus taught that the Psalms speak of him (Luke 24:44). After the Last Supper he and his disciples sang a hymn (Matthew 26:30), traditionally the Hallel, Psalms 113 to 118. On the cross he prayed the opening of Psalm 22 and, at the end, a line from Psalm 31 (Matthew 27:46; Luke 23:46). A plan meant to teach new believers how to speak to God, and not only what to believe about him, needs the Psalms at its heart.

Five Kinds of Day

The plan has five kinds of day. The Psalms are one of them, and the other four are built around them, so it helps to see how they fit together.

READING DAYS	472 days. The main readings that carry the story, the law, the prophets, and the letters.
PSALM DAYS	233 days. One psalm, or a short pair, set beside the surrounding reading.
DOCTRINAL PAUSES	44 days. A passage or two studied for one teaching of the faith.
UNIT REVIEWS	25 in all. Twenty-two take a day of their own, and three are combined with a Sabbath.
SABBATH REST	129, one for every week. In 126 the day is only rest, and in three it is combined with a review.

Psalm days are the second largest category, and on average they fall on a little under two days of each week. The plan was designed around that rhythm: narrative days carry the story forward, and psalm days let you stop and respond.

The Psalms by the Numbers

SHARE OF THE PLAN	233 of 900 days, about one in four.
COVERAGE	All 150 psalms are read at least once.

DIFFERENT READINGS	174. Long psalms are divided (Psalm 119 into several sections, and Psalms 18, 22, 78, 89, 104, and 107 into two) and 48 of the readings come back in a new setting.
PAIRED DAYS	16 days read two short psalms together.
TYPICAL LENGTH	About 16 verses (the middle reading is 13), against about 60 verses for a reading day.
YEAR 1 AND YEAR 2	158 psalm days in Year 1 and 75 in Year 2. The Old Testament is where most of the Psalms were written, and where they most often sit beside a story.
THE LARGEST BLOCK	Unit 9, The Davidic Covenant, has 31 psalm days out of 67.

What a Psalm Day Looks Like

A psalm day has the same seven parts as any reading day, so you always know what to expect. The differences are in emphasis. Because a psalm is a poem, the guide spends less time on events and more on structure, imagery, and the turns of thought. Setting the Scene gives the author, the heading, and the occasion if one is known. Observation points out repeated words, shifts of mood, and the line where a complaint becomes trust. Connection shows where the psalm points to Christ or where the New Testament quotes it. The Prayer at the end is only an echo. The psalm itself is the prayer.

The reading is short on purpose. A psalm is meant to be read aloud, slowly, and read again. You are not meant to finish it so much as stay with it.

Five Jobs the Psalms Do

They answer the story. Narrative shows what people did and what God did. The Psalms give the inner voice. After David's sin with Bathsheba and Nathan's rebuke, the plan gives you Psalms 32 and 51. After Absalom's revolt, it gives you Psalm 63. You do not only read that David repented. You hear how he prayed.

They interpret the story. Some psalms retell Israel's history as worship: Psalms 78, 105, 106, 114, 135, and 136. Others were written in the middle of a crisis you are reading about. Psalms 46, 48, and 76 stand beside Sennacherib's siege of Jerusalem. Psalm 90, attributed to Moses, comes among the first chapters of Numbers. Psalm 95 warns against a hard heart just after Israel's unbelief at Kadesh in Numbers 13 and 14. The Psalter becomes a commentary written by the people who lived it.

They carry Christ through the Old Testament. The New Testament leans on the Psalms to explain who Jesus is. In Unit 19 you read Psalms 2, 16, and 110 just after the apostles preach and pray from them. In Unit 22, you read Psalm 68, which Paul quotes in Ephesians 4 to describe the ascended Christ. In Unit 23, Psalms 95, 40, 110, and 22 sit beside Hebrews, which quotes all four. The psalm gives the first sound, and the New Testament gives the full chord.

They teach the whole range of prayer. The Psalms contain praise, thanksgiving, confession, lament, trust, wisdom, and anger. A new believer often assumes that only polite prayers are allowed. The Psalms say otherwise. They are included in all their range, and the hard ones are not skipped. Psalms 58, 109, and 137 call on God to judge those who do violence. The guide reads them honestly, as the cry of the oppressed handed over to God, and then in the light of Christ, who prayed for his enemies and who will judge the world in righteousness.

They set the pace. Heavy stretches of law, genealogy, and prophecy are followed by a short day of poetry. That keeps the plan humane. It is also a lesson in its own right: Scripture is meant to be prayed as well as studied.

How the Psalms Were Placed

No psalm was dropped in at random. Each one was set beside a reading it illuminates, using four kinds of placement.

Beside the event. The psalm is paired with the moment it most naturally belongs to, such as Psalms 32 and 51 after Nathan confronts David, or Psalm 63 after Absalom's revolt.

Beside the theme. The psalm takes up what the surrounding books are saying. Beside Job, the plan places the psalms of the suffering righteous: Psalms 10, 13, 22, 73, and 88. Beside Proverbs, it places Psalms 19 and 119 on the word of God. Beside Ecclesiastes, it places Psalms 49 and 73 on wealth and the brevity of life. Beside the Song of Solomon, it places Psalm 45.

Beside the quotation. When a New Testament author quotes a psalm, the plan places that psalm close by, so that you meet the original in its own setting before you see how it is used. This is one reason the Psalms cluster beside Acts and Hebrews.

At the edges. Psalms 1 and 2 are the front door of the Psalter, and they open the first run of David's psalms in Unit 9 (Days 237 and 239), return beside the Sermon on the Mount and the Transfiguration in Unit 15, and in Unit 25 as Revelation opens and as the nations rage. The last two psalm days of the plan, Days 897 and 898, are Psalm 72:18-19, the doxology that ends the second book of the Psalter, and Psalm 150, the final psalm of the Psalter itself.

Why Some Psalms Come Back

You will meet some psalms more than once, and that is on purpose. A psalm read beside a different story means something different. Psalm 2 appears four times: on Day 239 beside David's throne, on Day 586 beside the Father's voice at the Transfiguration, on Day 696 beside the prayer of the church in Acts 4, and on Day 884 as Revelation shows the nations raging. Psalm 22 appears five times: twice beside Job, then beside David, beside Isaiah's servant, and beside Hebrews. Psalm 110 appears five times, once on a doctrinal day.

When a psalm comes back, the guide gives it a new angle suited to the new setting. If you think, "I have read this before," you are right. Read it again, and notice what is different around it. Repetition is how the Bible itself teaches, and a psalm you already know is an old friend and not filler.

The Psalter's Five Books

The Psalms are gathered into five books: Psalms 1 to 41, 42 to 72, 73 to 89, 90 to 106, and 107 to 150. Each book ends with a short burst of praise called a doxology, and Psalm 150 closes the whole collection. The plan does not follow that order, because the order it follows is the order of the story. It does touch all five books, and it ends in the Psalter's own closing notes.

The Psalms Unit by Unit

UNIT	TITLE	PSALMS IN THIS UNIT
1	**Creation and the Covenant of Works**	Creation psalms (8, 19:1-6, 29, 33:1-9, 65, and 104) answer Genesis 1 and 2 with praise.
2	**Common Grace and the Noahic Covenant**	Psalms 9, 33:10-22, and 36:5-12 on God's care for the world and his judgment of the nations.
3	**The Abrahamic Covenant**	Psalm 105 retells the covenant with Abraham. Psalms 121, 124, 125, and 37 teach trust. Psalms 47 and 66 look to the nations.
4	**Job: Suffering and Sovereignty**	Psalms of the suffering righteous (10, 13, 22, 73, 88, 17, and 26) beside Job.
5	**The Mosaic Covenant I: Exodus**	Psalms 106, 77, 114, and 105:26-45 retell the exodus as worship.
6	**The Mosaic Covenant II: Tabernacle and Holiness**	Who may approach a holy God: Psalms 15, 24, 51, 50, 40, 91, and 92.
7	**Wilderness: Numbers and Deuteronomy**	Psalm 90 and Psalms 95, 96, 99, and 100 beside Numbers. Psalms 78 and 119 beside Deuteronomy.
8	**Conquest and Settlement**	God's victories and keeping in the land (Psalms 114, 46, 76), with prayers of trust and repentance (16, 23, 130).

9	**The Davidic Covenant**	The largest block. The psalms of David beside his story (32 and 51, 63, 34) and the royal and Zion psalms (2, 20, 21, 45, 72, 48, 84, 87, 101).
10	**Wisdom Literature**	Psalms 19 and 119 beside Proverbs. Psalms 49 and 73 beside Ecclesiastes. Psalm 45 beside the Song of Solomon.
11	**The Divided Kingdom and Early Prophets**	Laments and cries for justice (42 to 44, 58, 82, 94, 109, 74, 77) beside the prophets' protests.
12	**Hezekiah, Isaiah and the Assyrian Crisis**	Psalms 46, 48, 75, 76, 80, 81, and 83 beside Assyria's threat. Psalms 22, 69, and 89 beside Isaiah's servant.
13	**Exile: Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel**	Laments of exile (89:38-52, 137, 79), songs of hope (85, 102, 103, 106, 107), and ten of the fifteen Songs of Ascents.
14	**The Return and the Chronicles Perspective**	Songs of return (85, 107, 126), the closing praise psalms (145 to 150), the reign psalms (96 to 99), and temple psalms (115, 132, 135, 136).
15	**The New Covenant Inaugurated: Matthew**	Psalm 1 beside the Sermon on the Mount. Psalms 146 and 147 beside the healings. Psalms 2 and 110 beside the Transfiguration. Psalm 118 in Holy Week.
16	**The New Covenant Inaugurated: Luke**	Praise (113, 116, 117) and trust under pressure (27, 28, 31, 41, 55) beside Luke.
17	**The New Covenant Inaugurated: John**	Light (36, 43), the shepherd (23), and God's nearness (139, 100, 103) beside John.
18	**The New Covenant Inaugurated: Mark**	Psalms read beside Mark's stories: 107:23-43 (the storm), 89 (the Davidic king), 118:19-29 (the cornerstone), and 69 (the righteous sufferer).
19	**The New Covenant Applied: Acts**	Psalms 2, 16, and 110, which Peter preaches from, and mission psalms (67, 87, 117, 96, 98, 100).
20	**The New Covenant Explained: Romans**	Psalms 32, 143, 19, and 117, which Paul quotes in Romans, with 130 and 116.
21	**Law, Gospel and Church Life: Galatians, Corinthians**	Psalms 33, 62, 111, 112, and 133 on trust, generosity, and unity.
22	**In Christ: Prison and Pastoral Epistles**	The ascended Christ (68, 110) and trust under pressure (27, 138, 139).

23	**The Better Covenant: Hebrews**	Psalms 95, 40, 110, and 22, which Hebrews quotes.
24	**Faith Lived Out: General Epistles**	Speech, integrity, and the cornerstone (12, 15, 24, 34, 118:1-18, 31:1-8) beside the General Epistles.
25	**The New Covenant Consummated: Revelation**	Psalms 1, 19, and 29 at the opening. Throne psalms (2, 46, 93, 97) before the bowls. Psalms 72:18-19 and 150 at the close.

Reading a Psalm Day Well

- Read the psalm aloud, and then read it again. These were written to be heard.
- Notice the turn. Many psalms begin in complaint and end in trust, and the turn is where the lesson is.
- Let a hard psalm be hard. Read to the end before you decide what it means.
- Pray the psalm in your own words after you read it, using its shape but your own life.
- Sing it if you can. Many hymns are psalms set to music.
- Ask the question this whole plan asks: where is Christ in this psalm?

REFERENCE

Weekly Checklist

All 129 weeks, Sunday through Saturday. Check each day as you finish it. Six days of reading, then a Sabbath rest on Saturday. Begin on any Sunday.

WEEK	SUN	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	DONE
Year 1: PROMISE AND SHADOW · Unit 1: Creation and the Covenant of Works (begins this week)								
1	☐ **Day 1** Genesis 1:1-2:3	☐ **Day 2** Doctrine: The Doctrine of Scripture (Bibliology)	☐ **Day 3** Genesis 2:4-25	☐ **Day 4** Doctrine: The Image of God	☐ **Day 5** Genesis 3:1-24	☐ **Day 6** Doctrine: The Doctrine of Sin (Hamartiology)	☐ **Day 7** Sabbath rest	☐
2	☐ **Day 8** Psalm 8	☐ **Day 9** Psalm 104:1-23	☐ **Day 10** Psalm 104:24-35	☐ **Day 11** Psalm 19:1-6	☐ **Day 12** Psalm 33:1-9	☐ **Day 13** Psalm 29	☐ **Day 14** Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 2: Common Grace and the Noahic Covenant (begins Day 17)								
3	☐ **Day 15** Psalm 65	☐ **Day 16** Unit review	☐ **Day 17** Genesis 4:1-26	☐ **Day 18** Genesis 5:1-32	☐ **Day 19** Genesis 6:1-22	☐ **Day 20** Genesis 7:1-8:19	☐ **Day 21** Sabbath rest	☐
4	☐ **Day 22** Genesis 8:20-9:29	☐ **Day 23** Genesis 10:1-11:32	☐ **Day 24** Psalm 36:5-12	☐ **Day 25** Psalm 33:10-22	☐ **Day 26** Psalm 9	☐ **Day 27** Unit review	☐ **Day 28** Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 3: The Abrahamic Covenant (begins this week)								
5	☐ **Day 29** Genesis 12:1-13:18	☐ **Day 30** Genesis 14:1-24	☐ **Day 31** Genesis 15:1-21	☐ **Day 32** Doctrine: Covenant Theology, A Framework	☐ **Day 33** Psalm 105:1-22	☐ **Day 34** Genesis 16:1-17:27	☐ **Day 35** Sabbath rest	☐
6	☐ **Day 36** Genesis 18:1-19:38	☐ **Day 37** Genesis 20:1-21:34	☐ **Day 38** Genesis 22:1-24	☐ **Day 39** Psalm 105:23-45	☐ **Day 40** Genesis 23:1-24:67	☐ **Day 41** Genesis 25:1-26:35	☐ **Day 42** Sabbath rest	☐
7	☐ **Day 43** Genesis 27:1-28:22	☐ **Day 44** Genesis 29:1-30:43	☐ **Day 45** Psalm 121	☐ **Day 46** Psalm 124; Psalm 125	☐ **Day 47** Genesis 31:1-32:32	☐ **Day 48** Genesis 33:1-35:29	☐ **Day 49** Sabbath rest	☐
8	☐ **Day 50** Genesis 36:1-37:36	☐ **Day 51** Genesis 38:1-39:23	☐ **Day 52** Psalm 37:1-22	☐ **Day 53** Psalm 37:23-40	☐ **Day 54** Genesis 40:1-41:57	☐ **Day 55** Genesis 42:1-43:34	☐ **Day 56** Sabbath rest	☐
9	☐ **Day 57** Genesis 44:1-45:28	☐ **Day 58** Genesis 46:1-47:31	☐ **Day 59** Genesis 48:1-50:26	☐ **Day 60** Psalm 47	☐ **Day 61** Psalm 66:1-7	☐ **Day 62** Unit review	☐ **Day 63** Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 4: Job: Suffering and Sovereignty (begins this week)								
10	☐ **Day 64** Job 1:1-2:13	☐ **Day 65** Psalm 10	☐ **Day 66** Psalm 13	☐ **Day 67** Job 3:1-4:21	☐ **Day 68** Job 5:1-7:21	☐ **Day 69** Job 8:1-10:22	☐ **Day 70** Sabbath rest	☐

WEEK	SUN	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	DONE
11	☐ Day 71 Job 11:1-13:28	☐ Day 72 Job 14:1-17:16	☐ Day 73 Psalm 22:1-21	☐ Day 74 Psalm 22:22-31	☐ Day 75 Job 18:1-20:29	☐ Day 76 Job 21:1-23:17	☐ Day 77 Sabbath rest	☐
12	☐ Day 78 Job 24:1-26:14	☐ Day 79 Job 27:1-28:28	☐ Day 80 Job 29:1-31:40	☐ Day 81 Job 32:1-34:37	☐ Day 82 Job 35:1-37:24	☐ Day 83 Job 38:1-39:30	☐ Day 84 Sabbath rest	☐
13	☐ Day 85 Job 40:1-42:17	☐ Day 86 Doctrine: The Decrees of God and Providence	☐ Day 87 Doctrine: Suffering and the Christian Life	☐ Day 88 Psalm 73	☐ Day 89 Psalm 88	☐ Day 90 Psalm 17	☐ Day 91 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 5: The Mosaic Covenant I: Exodus (begins Day 94)								
14	☐ Day 92 Psalm 26	☐ Day 93 Unit review	☐ Day 94 Exodus 1:1-2:25	☐ Day 95 Exodus 3:1-4:31	☐ Day 96 Doctrine: The Existence and Attributes of God	☐ Day 97 Psalm 106:1-23	☐ Day 98 Sabbath rest	☐
15	☐ Day 99 Exodus 5:1-7:25	☐ Day 100 Exodus 8:1-9:35	☐ Day 101 Exodus 10:1-11:10	☐ Day 102 Exodus 12:1-13:16	☐ Day 103 Exodus 13:17-14:31	☐ Day 104 Psalm 106:24-48	☐ Day 105 Sabbath rest	☐
16	☐ Day 106 Exodus 15:1-27	☐ Day 107 Psalm 77	☐ Day 108 Psalm 114	☐ Day 109 Exodus 16:1-18:27	☐ Day 110 Exodus 19:1-20:26	☐ Day 111 Doctrine: The Moral Law and the Christian	☐ Day 112 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 6: The Mosaic Covenant II: Tabernacle and Holiness (begins Day 117)								
17	☐ Day 113 Exodus 21:1-22:31	☐ Day 114 Exodus 23:1-24:18	☐ Day 115 Psalm 105:26-45	☐ Day 116 Unit review	☐ Day 117 Exodus 25:1-26:37	☐ Day 118 Exodus 27:1-28:43	☐ Day 119 Sabbath rest	☐
18	☐ Day 120 Exodus 29:1-46	☐ Day 121 Exodus 30:1-31:18	☐ Day 122 Exodus 32:1-33:23	☐ Day 123 Exodus 34:1-35:35	☐ Day 124 Psalm 15	☐ Day 125 Psalm 24	☐ Day 126 Sabbath rest	☐
19	☐ Day 127 Exodus 36:1-38:31	☐ Day 128 Exodus 39:1-40:38	☐ Day 129 Leviticus 1:1-3:17	☐ Day 130 Leviticus 4:1-5:19	☐ Day 131 Leviticus 6:1-7:38	☐ Day 132 Leviticus 8:1-10:20	☐ Day 133 Sabbath rest	☐
20	☐ Day 134 Leviticus 11:1-13:59	☐ Day 135 Leviticus 14:1-15:33	☐ Day 136 Leviticus 16:1-34	☐ Day 137 Psalm 51	☐ Day 138 Leviticus 17:1-19:37	☐ Day 139 Leviticus 20:1-22:33	☐ Day 140 Sabbath rest	☐
21	☐ Day 141 Leviticus 23:1-24:23	☐ Day 142 Leviticus 25:1-26:46	☐ Day 143 Leviticus 27:1-34	☐ Day 144 Psalm 50	☐ Day 145 Psalm 40:1-10	☐ Day 146 Psalm 91	☐ Day 147 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 7: Wilderness: Numbers and Deuteronomy (begins Day 150)								
22	☐ Day 148 Psalm 92	☐ Day 149 Unit review	☐ Day 150 Numbers 1:1-2:34	☐ Day 151 Numbers 3:1-4:49	☐ Day 152 Numbers 5:1-6:27	☐ Day 153 Psalm 90	☐ Day 154 Sabbath rest	☐

WEEK	SUN	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	DONE
23	☐ Day 155 Numbers 7:1-89	☐ Day 156 Numbers 8:1-10:36	☐ Day 157 Numbers 11:1-12:16	☐ Day 158 Numbers 13:1-14:45	☐ Day 159 Psalm 95	☐ Day 160 Psalm 96	☐ Day 161 Sabbath rest	☐
24	☐ Day 162 Numbers 15:1-16:50	☐ Day 163 Numbers 17:1-19:22	☐ Day 164 Numbers 20:1-21:35	☐ Day 165 Numbers 22:1-24:25	☐ Day 166 Psalm 99	☐ Day 167 Psalm 100	☐ Day 168 Sabbath rest	☐
25	☐ Day 169 Numbers 25:1-27:23	☐ Day 170 Numbers 28:1-30:16	☐ Day 171 Numbers 31:1-32:42	☐ Day 172 Numbers 33:1-34:29	☐ Day 173 Numbers 35:1-36:13	☐ Day 174 Deuteronomy 1:1-3:29	☐ Day 175 Sabbath rest	☐
26	☐ Day 176 Psalm 78:1-39	☐ Day 177 Deuteronomy 4:1-5:33	☐ Day 178 Deuteronomy 6:1-8:20	☐ Day 179 Deuteronomy 9:1-11:32	☐ Day 180 Psalm 78:40-72	☐ Day 181 Deuteronomy 12:1-14:29	☐ Day 182 Sabbath rest	☐
27	☐ Day 183 Deuteronomy 15:1-16:22	☐ Day 184 Doctrine: The Three Offices of Christ, Prophet, Priest, King	☐ Day 185 Deuteronomy 17:1-18:22	☐ Day 186 Deuteronomy 19:1-21:23	☐ Day 187 Deuteronomy 22:1-25:19	☐ Day 188 Deuteronomy 26:1-28:14	☐ Day 189 Sabbath rest	☐
28	☐ Day 190 Psalm 119:1-48	☐ Day 191 Psalm 119:49-96	☐ Day 192 Deuteronomy 28:15-68	☐ Day 193 Deuteronomy 29:1-31:29	☐ Day 194 Deuteronomy 31:30-32:52	☐ Day 195 Deuteronomy 33:1-34:12	☐ Day 196 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 8: Conquest and Settlement (begins Day 200)								
29	☐ Day 197 Psalm 119:97-144	☐ Day 198 Psalm 119:145-176	☐ Day 199 Unit review	☐ Day 200 Joshua 1:1-2:24	☐ Day 201 Joshua 3:1-5:15	☐ Day 202 Psalm 114	☐ Day 203 Sabbath rest	☐
30	☐ Day 204 Psalm 66:1-12	☐ Day 205 Joshua 6:1-8:35	☐ Day 206 Joshua 9:1-10:43	☐ Day 207 Joshua 11:1-12:24	☐ Day 208 Joshua 13:1-17:18	☐ Day 209 Psalm 16	☐ Day 210 Sabbath rest	☐
31	☐ Day 211 Psalm 23	☐ Day 212 Joshua 18:1-19:51	☐ Day 213 Joshua 20:1-22:34	☐ Day 214 Joshua 23:1-24:33	☐ Day 215 Judges 1:1-3:31	☐ Day 216 Judges 4:1-5:31	☐ Day 217 Sabbath rest	☐
32	☐ Day 218 Psalm 46	☐ Day 219 Psalm 76	☐ Day 220 Judges 6:1-8:35	☐ Day 221 Judges 9:1-10:18	☐ Day 222 Judges 11:1-12:15	☐ Day 223 Judges 13:1-14:20	☐ Day 224 Sabbath rest	☐
33	☐ Day 225 Judges 15:1-16:31	☐ Day 226 Psalm 130	☐ Day 227 Psalm 40:1-10	☐ Day 228 Judges 17:1-18:31	☐ Day 229 Judges 19:1-21:25	☐ Day 230 Ruth 1:1-2:23	☐ Day 231 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 9: The Davidic Covenant (begins Day 235)								
34	☐ Day 232 Ruth 3:1-4:22	☐ Day 233 Psalm 127; Psalm 128	☐ Day 234 Unit review	☐ Day 235 1 Samuel 1:1-2:36	☐ Day 236 1 Samuel 3:1-4:22	☐ Day 237 Psalm 1	☐ Day 238 Sabbath rest	☐

WEEK	SUN	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	DONE
35	☐ Day 239 Psalm 2	☐ Day 240 1 Samuel 5:1-7:17	☐ Day 241 1 Samuel 8:1-10:27	☐ Day 242 1 Samuel 11:1-13:23	☐ Day 243 Psalm 3	☐ Day 244 Psalm 4; Psalm 5	☐ Day 245 Sabbath rest	☐
36	☐ Day 246 Psalm 6	☐ Day 247 1 Samuel 14:1-15:35	☐ Day 248 1 Samuel 16:1-17:58	☐ Day 249 1 Samuel 18:1-20:42	☐ Day 250 Psalm 7	☐ Day 251 Psalm 11; Psalm 12	☐ Day 252 Sabbath rest	☐
37	☐ Day 253 Psalm 13; Psalm 14	☐ Day 254 1 Samuel 21:1-23:29	☐ Day 255 1 Samuel 24:1-26:25	☐ Day 256 Psalm 18:1-30	☐ Day 257 Psalm 18:31-50	☐ Day 258 Psalm 54; Psalm 59	☐ Day 259 Sabbath rest	☐
38	☐ Day 260 Psalm 64; Psalm 70	☐ Day 261 1 Samuel 27:1-31:13	☐ Day 262 2 Samuel 1:1-3:39	☐ Day 263 Psalm 20	☐ Day 264 Psalm 21	☐ Day 265 2 Samuel 4:1-6:23	☐ Day 266 Sabbath rest	☐
39	☐ Day 267 2 Samuel 7:1-29	☐ Day 268 Psalm 22:1-21	☐ Day 269 Psalm 24	☐ Day 270 2 Samuel 8:1-10:19	☐ Day 271 2 Samuel 11:1-12:31	☐ Day 272 Psalm 32	☐ Day 273 Sabbath rest	☐
40	☐ Day 274 Psalm 51	☐ Day 275 2 Samuel 13:1-14:33	☐ Day 276 2 Samuel 15:1-17:29	☐ Day 277 Psalm 63	☐ Day 278 Psalm 61	☐ Day 279 2 Samuel 18:1-19:43	☐ Day 280 Sabbath rest	☐
41	☐ Day 281 2 Samuel 20:1-22:51	☐ Day 282 Psalm 34	☐ Day 283 Psalm 56; Psalm 57	☐ Day 284 Psalm 30	☐ Day 285 Psalm 35	☐ Day 286 Psalm 38; Psalm 39	☐ Day 287 Sabbath rest	☐
42	☐ Day 288 2 Samuel 23:1-24:25	☐ Day 289 1 Kings 1:1-2:46	☐ Day 290 Psalm 45	☐ Day 291 Psalm 72	☐ Day 292 1 Kings 3:1-5:18	☐ Day 293 1 Kings 6:1-7:51	☐ Day 294 Sabbath rest	☐
43	☐ Day 295 1 Kings 8:1-66	☐ Day 296 Psalm 48	☐ Day 297 Psalm 84	☐ Day 298 Psalm 87	☐ Day 299 Psalm 101	☐ Day 300 1 Kings 9:1-11:43	☐ Day 301 Unit review and Sabbath	☐
Unit 10: Wisdom Literature (begins this week)								
44	☐ Day 302 Proverbs 1:1-2:22	☐ Day 303 Proverbs 3:1-4:27	☐ Day 304 Proverbs 5:1-6:35	☐ Day 305 Psalm 19	☐ Day 306 Psalm 119:1-40	☐ Day 307 Proverbs 7:1-8:36	☐ Day 308 Sabbath rest	☐
45	☐ Day 309 Proverbs 9:1-11:31	☐ Day 310 Proverbs 12:1-14:35	☐ Day 311 Psalm 119:41-96	☐ Day 312 Proverbs 15:1-17:28	☐ Day 313 Proverbs 18:1-19:29	☐ Day 314 Proverbs 20:1-21:31	☐ Day 315 Sabbath rest	☐
46	☐ Day 316 Proverbs 22:1-24:34	☐ Day 317 Psalm 119:97-144	☐ Day 318 Proverbs 25:1-27:27	☐ Day 319 Proverbs 28:1-29:27	☐ Day 320 Proverbs 30:1-31:31	☐ Day 321 Ecclesiastes 1:1-2:26	☐ Day 322 Sabbath rest	☐
47	☐ Day 323 Ecclesiastes 3:1-4:16	☐ Day 324 Psalm 49	☐ Day 325 Psalm 73	☐ Day 326 Ecclesiastes 5:1-7:29	☐ Day 327 Ecclesiastes 8:1-10:20	☐ Day 328 Ecclesiastes 11:1-12:14	☐ Day 329 Sabbath rest	☐

WEEK	SUN	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	DONE
Unit 11: The Divided Kingdom and Early Prophets (begins Day 334)								
48	☐ **Day 330** Song of Solomon 1:1-4:16	☐ **Day 331** Song of Solomon 5:1-8:14	☐ **Day 332** Psalm 45	☐ **Day 333** Unit review	☐ **Day 334** 1 Kings 12:1-14:20	☐ **Day 335** 1 Kings 14:21-16:34	☐ **Day 336** Sabbath rest	☐
49	☐ **Day 337** Psalm 42	☐ **Day 338** Psalm 43	☐ **Day 339** 1 Kings 17:1-19:21	☐ **Day 340** 1 Kings 20:1-22:53	☐ **Day 341** 2 Kings 1:1-2:25	☐ **Day 342** 2 Kings 3:1-4:44	☐ **Day 343** Sabbath rest	☐
50	☐ **Day 344** Psalm 44	☐ **Day 345** Psalm 60	☐ **Day 346** 2 Kings 5:1-6:33	☐ **Day 347** 2 Kings 7:1-8:29	☐ **Day 348** 2 Kings 9:1-10:36	☐ **Day 349** 2 Kings 11:1-13:25	☐ **Day 350** Sabbath rest	☐
51	☐ **Day 351** Psalm 50	☐ **Day 352** Psalm 52; Psalm 53	☐ **Day 353** 2 Kings 14:1-15:38	☐ **Day 354** Amos 1:1-2:16	☐ **Day 355** Amos 3:1-5:27	☐ **Day 356** Amos 6:1-9:15	☐ **Day 357** Sabbath rest	☐
52	☐ **Day 358** Psalm 58	☐ **Day 359** Psalm 82	☐ **Day 360** Psalm 94	☐ **Day 361** Psalm 109	☐ **Day 362** Psalm 140; Psalm 142	☐ **Day 363** Hosea 1:1-3:5	☐ **Day 364** Sabbath rest	☐
53	☐ **Day 365** Hosea 4:1-7:16	☐ **Day 366** Hosea 8:1-11:12	☐ **Day 367** Hosea 12:1-14:9	☐ **Day 368** Psalm 74	☐ **Day 369** Psalm 77	☐ **Day 370** Jonah 1:1-2:10	☐ **Day 371** Sabbath rest	☐
54	☐ **Day 372** Jonah 3:1-4:11	☐ **Day 373** Micah 1:1-3:12	☐ **Day 374** Micah 4:1-5:15	☐ **Day 375** Micah 6:1-7:20	☐ **Day 376** 2 Kings 16:1-17:41	☐ **Day 377** Unit review	☐ **Day 378** Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 12: Hezekiah, Isaiah and the Assyrian Crisis (begins this week)								
55	☐ **Day 379** 2 Kings 18:1-20:21	☐ **Day 380** Isaiah 1:1-3:26	☐ **Day 381** Isaiah 4:1-5:30	☐ **Day 382** Psalm 80	☐ **Day 383** Psalm 81	☐ **Day 384** Isaiah 6:1-8:22	☐ **Day 385** Sabbath rest	☐
56	☐ **Day 386** Doctrine: The holiness of God	☐ **Day 387** Isaiah 9:1-12:6	☐ **Day 388** Isaiah 13:1-17:14	☐ **Day 389** Isaiah 18:1-23:18	☐ **Day 390** Psalm 75	☐ **Day 391** Psalm 76	☐ **Day 392** Sabbath rest	☐
57	☐ **Day 393** Psalm 83	☐ **Day 394** Isaiah 24:1-27:13	☐ **Day 395** Isaiah 28:1-30:33	☐ **Day 396** Isaiah 31:1-35:10	☐ **Day 397** Isaiah 36:1-37:38	☐ **Day 398** Isaiah 38:1-39:8	☐ **Day 399** Sabbath rest	☐
58	☐ **Day 400** Psalm 46	☐ **Day 401** Psalm 48	☐ **Day 402** Isaiah 40:1-42:25	☐ **Day 403** Isaiah 43:1-45:25	☐ **Day 404** Psalm 86	☐ **Day 405** Psalm 89:1-37	☐ **Day 406** Sabbath rest	☐
59	☐ **Day 407** Isaiah 46:1-49:26	☐ **Day 408** Isaiah 50:1-53:12	☐ **Day 409** Doctrine: The Work of Christ, Atonement	☐ **Day 410** Isaiah 54:1-57:21	☐ **Day 411** Psalm 22	☐ **Day 412** Psalm 69:1-21	☐ **Day 413** Sabbath rest	☐

WEEK	SUN	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	DONE
60	☐ Day 414 Isaiah 58:1-60:22	☐ Day 415 Isaiah 61:1-63:14	☐ Day 416 Isaiah 63:15-66:24	☐ Day 417 Nahum 1:1-3:19	☐ Day 418 Habakkuk 1:1-3:19	☐ Day 419 Zephaniah 1:1-3:20	☐ Day 420 Unit review and Sabbath	☐
Unit 13: Exile: Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel (begins this week)								
61	☐ Day 421 2 Kings 21:1-23:37	☐ Day 422 2 Kings 24:1-25:30	☐ Day 423 Psalm 89:38-52	☐ Day 424 Psalm 137	☐ Day 425 Jeremiah 1:1-3:5	☐ Day 426 Jeremiah 3:6-6:30	☐ Day 427 Sabbath rest	☐
62	☐ Day 428 Jeremiah 7:1-9:26	☐ Day 429 Psalm 79	☐ Day 430 Psalm 85	☐ Day 431 Jeremiah 10:1-13:27	☐ Day 432 Jeremiah 14:1-17:27	☐ Day 433 Jeremiah 18:1-20:18	☐ Day 434 Sabbath rest	☐
63	☐ Day 435 Psalm 102	☐ Day 436 Psalm 103	☐ Day 437 Jeremiah 21:1-24:10	☐ Day 438 Jeremiah 25:1-27:22	☐ Day 439 Jeremiah 28:1-29:32	☐ Day 440 Psalm 106	☐ Day 441 Sabbath rest	☐
64	☐ Day 442 Psalm 107:1-22	☐ Day 443 Jeremiah 30:1-31:40	☐ Day 444 Jeremiah 32:1-33:26	☐ Day 445 Jeremiah 34:1-36:32	☐ Day 446 Jeremiah 37:1-39:18	☐ Day 447 Psalm 107:23-43	☐ Day 448 Sabbath rest	☐
65	☐ Day 449 Psalm 108	☐ Day 450 Jeremiah 40:1-42:22	☐ Day 451 Jeremiah 43:1-45:5	☐ Day 452 Jeremiah 46:1-48:47	☐ Day 453 Jeremiah 49:1-51:64	☐ Day 454 Jeremiah 52:1-34	☐ Day 455 Sabbath rest	☐
66	☐ Day 456 Psalm 119:145-176	☐ Day 457 Psalm 120; Psalm 121	☐ Day 458 Lamentations 1:1-2:22	☐ Day 459 Lamentations 3:1-66	☐ Day 460 Lamentations 4:1-5:22	☐ Day 461 Ezekiel 1:1-3:27	☐ Day 462 Sabbath rest	☐
67	☐ Day 463 Psalm 73	☐ Day 464 Psalm 77	☐ Day 465 Ezekiel 4:1-7:27	☐ Day 466 Ezekiel 8:1-11:25	☐ Day 467 Ezekiel 12:1-14:23	☐ Day 468 Ezekiel 15:1-17:24	☐ Day 469 Sabbath rest	☐
68	☐ Day 470 Psalm 122	☐ Day 471 Psalm 123; Psalm 126	☐ Day 472 Ezekiel 18:1-20:49	☐ Day 473 Ezekiel 21:1-24:27	☐ Day 474 Ezekiel 25:1-28:26	☐ Day 475 Ezekiel 29:1-32:32	☐ Day 476 Sabbath rest	☐
69	☐ Day 477 Psalm 128; Psalm 129	☐ Day 478 Psalm 131; Psalm 133; Psalm 134	☐ Day 479 Ezekiel 33:1-35:15	☐ Day 480 Ezekiel 36:1-37:28	☐ Day 481 Ezekiel 38:1-39:29	☐ Day 482 Ezekiel 40:1-43:27	☐ Day 483 Sabbath rest	☐
70	☐ Day 484 Ezekiel 44:1-46:24	☐ Day 485 Ezekiel 47:1-48:35	☐ Day 486 Daniel 1:1-2:49	☐ Day 487 Daniel 3:1-4:37	☐ Day 488 Psalm 135	☐ Day 489 Psalm 136	☐ Day 490 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 14: The Return and the Chronicles Perspective (begins Day 496)								
71	☐ Day 491 Daniel 5:1-6:28	☐ Day 492 Daniel 7:1-8:27	☐ Day 493 Daniel 9:1-10:21	☐ Day 494 Daniel 11:1-12:13	☐ Day 495 Unit review	☐ Day 496 Ezra 1:1-3:13	☐ Day 497 Sabbath rest	☐

WEEK	SUN	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	DONE
72	☐ Day 498 Ezra 4:1-6:22	☐ Day 499 Psalm 126	☐ Day 500 Psalm 85	☐ Day 501 Psalm 107:1-22	☐ Day 502 Ezra 7:1-8:36	☐ Day 503 Ezra 9:1-10:44	☐ Day 504 Sabbath rest	☐
73	☐ Day 505 Nehemiah 1:1-2:20	☐ Day 506 Nehemiah 3:1-4:23	☐ Day 507 Nehemiah 5:1-7:73	☐ Day 508 Psalm 147	☐ Day 509 Psalm 148	☐ Day 510 Nehemiah 8:1-10:39	☐ Day 511 Sabbath rest	☐
74	☐ Day 512 Nehemiah 11:1-13:31	☐ Day 513 Esther 1:1-3:15	☐ Day 514 Esther 4:1-7:10	☐ Day 515 Esther 8:1-10:3	☐ Day 516 Psalm 145	☐ Day 517 Psalm 149; Psalm 150	☐ Day 518 Sabbath rest	☐
75	☐ Day 519 Psalm 115	☐ Day 520 Psalm 71	☐ Day 521 Psalm 144	☐ Day 522 1 Chronicles 1:1-2:55	☐ Day 523 1 Chronicles 3:1-5:26	☐ Day 524 1 Chronicles 6:1-9:44	☐ Day 525 Sabbath rest	☐
76	☐ Day 526 1 Chronicles 10:1-13:14	☐ Day 527 1 Chronicles 14:1-17:27	☐ Day 528 Psalm 96	☐ Day 529 Psalm 105:1-15	☐ Day 530 1 Chronicles 18:1-22:19	☐ Day 531 1 Chronicles 23:1-26:32	☐ Day 532 Sabbath rest	☐
77	☐ Day 533 1 Chronicles 27:1-29:30	☐ Day 534 2 Chronicles 1:1-4:22	☐ Day 535 2 Chronicles 5:1-7:22	☐ Day 536 Psalm 132	☐ Day 537 Psalm 135	☐ Day 538 Psalm 136	☐ Day 539 Sabbath rest	☐
78	☐ Day 540 2 Chronicles 8:1-12:16	☐ Day 541 2 Chronicles 13:1-16:14	☐ Day 542 2 Chronicles 17:1-20:37	☐ Day 543 2 Chronicles 21:1-24:27	☐ Day 544 2 Chronicles 25:1-28:27	☐ Day 545 2 Chronicles 29:1-32:33	☐ Day 546 Sabbath rest	☐
79	☐ Day 547 2 Chronicles 33:1-36:23	☐ Day 548 Joel 1:1-2:32	☐ Day 549 Joel 3:1-21	☐ Day 550 Obadiah 1:1-21	☐ Day 551 Psalm 97	☐ Day 552 Psalm 98	☐ Day 553 Sabbath rest	☐
80	☐ Day 554 Psalm 99	☐ Day 555 Haggai 1:1-2:23	☐ Day 556 Zechariah 1:1-3:10	☐ Day 557 Zechariah 4:1-6:15	☐ Day 558 Zechariah 7:1-8:23	☐ Day 559 Zechariah 9:1-11:17	☐ Day 560 Sabbath rest	☐
Year 2: FULFILLMENT · Unit 15: The New Covenant Inaugurated: Matthew (begins Day 565)								
81	☐ Day 561 Zechariah 12:1-14:21	☐ Day 562 Malachi 1:1-2:17	☐ Day 563 Malachi 3:1-4:6	☐ Day 564 Unit review	☐ Day 565 Matthew 1:1-2:23	☐ Day 566 Matthew 3:1-4:25	☐ Day 567 Sabbath rest	☐
82	☐ Day 568 Matthew 5:1-20	☐ Day 569 Matthew 5:21-48	☐ Day 570 Matthew 6:1-34	☐ Day 571 Doctrine: Prayer	☐ Day 572 Matthew 7:1-29	☐ Day 573 Psalm 1	☐ Day 574 Sabbath rest	☐
83	☐ Day 575 Psalm 146	☐ Day 576 Psalm 147:1-11	☐ Day 577 Matthew 8:1-9:38	☐ Day 578 Matthew 10:1-11:30	☐ Day 579 Matthew 12:1-13:23	☐ Day 580 Psalm 78:1-16	☐ Day 581 Sabbath rest	☐
84	☐ Day 582 Psalm 25	☐ Day 583 Matthew 13:24-14:36	☐ Day 584 Matthew 15:1-16:28	☐ Day 585 Matthew 17:1-18:35	☐ Day 586 Psalm 2	☐ Day 587 Psalm 110	☐ Day 588 Sabbath rest	☐

WEEK	SUN	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	DONE
85	☐ Day 589 Matthew 19:1-20:34	☐ Day 590 Matthew 21:1-22:14	☐ Day 591 Matthew 22:15-23:39	☐ Day 592 Matthew 24:1-25:46	☐ Day 593 Psalm 118	☐ Day 594 Matthew 26:1-46	☐ Day 595 Sabbath rest	☐
86	☐ Day 596 Matthew 26:47-27:31	☐ Day 597 Matthew 27:32-66	☐ Day 598 Matthew 28:1-20	☐ Day 599 Doctrine: The Trinity	☐ Day 600 Doctrine: The Sacraments, Baptism	☐ Day 601 Unit review	☐ Day 602 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 16: The New Covenant Inaugurated: Luke (begins this week)								
87	☐ Day 603 Luke 1:1-80	☐ Day 604 Luke 2:1-52	☐ Day 605 Luke 3:1-4:13	☐ Day 606 Luke 4:14-5:39	☐ Day 607 Luke 6:1-49	☐ Day 608 Psalm 113	☐ Day 609 Sabbath rest	☐
88	☐ Day 610 Psalm 116	☐ Day 611 Psalm 117	☐ Day 612 Luke 7:1-8:21	☐ Day 613 Luke 8:22-9:50	☐ Day 614 Luke 9:51-11:13	☐ Day 615 Luke 11:14-13:21	☐ Day 616 Sabbath rest	☐
89	☐ Day 617 Psalm 27	☐ Day 618 Psalm 28	☐ Day 619 Psalm 31:1-18	☐ Day 620 Luke 13:22-15:32	☐ Day 621 Luke 16:1-17:37	☐ Day 622 Luke 18:1-19:27	☐ Day 623 Sabbath rest	☐
90	☐ Day 624 Luke 19:28-21:38	☐ Day 625 Psalm 31:19-24	☐ Day 626 Psalm 41	☐ Day 627 Psalm 55:1-23	☐ Day 628 Luke 22:1-46	☐ Day 629 Luke 22:47-23:25	☐ Day 630 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 17: The New Covenant Inaugurated: John (begins Day 634)								
91	☐ Day 631 Luke 23:26-56	☐ Day 632 Luke 24:1-53	☐ Day 633 Unit review	☐ Day 634 John 1:1-51	☐ Day 635 Doctrine: The Person of Christ, Incarnation	☐ Day 636 John 2:1-3:36	☐ Day 637 Sabbath rest	☐
92	☐ Day 638 Doctrine: Regeneration and the New Birth	☐ Day 639 Psalm 36	☐ Day 640 Psalm 139:1-18	☐ Day 641 John 4:1-54	☐ Day 642 Doctrine: Worship	☐ Day 643 John 5:1-47	☐ Day 644 Sabbath rest	☐
93	☐ Day 645 John 6:1-71	☐ Day 646 John 7:1-8:11	☐ Day 647 John 8:12-59	☐ Day 648 Psalm 119:97-120	☐ Day 649 Psalm 43	☐ Day 650 John 9:1-10:21	☐ Day 651 Sabbath rest	☐
94	☐ Day 652 John 10:22-11:57	☐ Day 653 John 12:1-50	☐ Day 654 John 13:1-14:31	☐ Day 655 Psalm 23	☐ Day 656 Psalm 100	☐ Day 657 Psalm 103	☐ Day 658 Sabbath rest	☐
95	☐ Day 659 John 15:1-16:33	☐ Day 660 John 17:1-26	☐ Day 661 John 18:1-19:16	☐ Day 662 John 19:17-42	☐ Day 663 John 20:1-21:25	☐ Day 664 Unit review	☐ Day 665 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 18: The New Covenant Inaugurated: Mark (begins this week)								
96	☐ Day 666 Mark 1:1-45	☐ Day 667 Doctrine: Inaugurated eschatology	☐ Day 668 Mark 2:1-3:35	☐ Day 669 Mark 4:1-5:43	☐ Day 670 Mark 6:1-56	☐ Day 671 Psalm 107:23-43	☐ Day 672 Sabbath rest	☐

WEEK	SUN	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	DONE
97	☐ Day 673 Psalm 89:1-18	☐ Day 674 Mark 7:1-8:38	☐ Day 675 Mark 9:1-50	☐ Day 676 Mark 10:1-52	☐ Day 677 Mark 11:1-12:44	☐ Day 678 Mark 13:1-37	☐ Day 679 Sabbath rest	☐
98	☐ Day 680 Psalm 118:19-29	☐ Day 681 Psalm 69:1-21	☐ Day 682 Mark 14:1-52	☐ Day 683 Mark 14:53-15:20	☐ Day 684 Mark 15:21-47	☐ Day 685 Mark 16:1-20	☐ Day 686 Unit review and Sabbath	☐
Unit 19: The New Covenant Applied: Acts (begins this week)								
99	☐ Day 687 Acts 1:1-26	☐ Day 688 Doctrine: Christ ascended and reigning	☐ Day 689 Doctrine: The Person and Work of the Holy Spirit	☐ Day 690 Doctrine: Turning from sin to God	☐ Day 691 Doctrine: The Means of Grace, Word, Sacrament, Prayer	☐ Day 692 Acts 2:1-47	☐ Day 693 Sabbath rest	☐
100	☐ Day 694 Acts 3:1-4:31	☐ Day 695 Acts 4:32-6:7	☐ Day 696 Psalm 2	☐ Day 697 Psalm 16	☐ Day 698 Psalm 110:1-7	☐ Day 699 Acts 6:8-8:3	☐ Day 700 Sabbath rest	☐
101	☐ Day 701 Acts 8:4-40	☐ Day 702 Acts 9:1-43	☐ Day 703 Acts 10:1-11:30	☐ Day 704 Acts 12:1-13:52	☐ Day 705 Psalm 67	☐ Day 706 Psalm 87	☐ Day 707 Sabbath rest	☐
102	☐ Day 708 Psalm 117	☐ Day 709 Acts 14:1-28	☐ Day 710 Acts 15:1-41	☐ Day 711 Acts 16:1-40	☐ Day 712 Acts 17:1-18:28	☐ Day 713 Acts 19:1-41	☐ Day 714 Sabbath rest	☐
103	☐ Day 715 Acts 20:1-38	☐ Day 716 Psalm 96	☐ Day 717 Psalm 98	☐ Day 718 Psalm 100	☐ Day 719 Acts 21:1-22:30	☐ Day 720 Acts 23:1-24:27	☐ Day 721 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 20: The New Covenant Explained: Romans (begins Day 725)								
104	☐ Day 722 Acts 25:1-26:32	☐ Day 723 Acts 27:1-28:31	☐ Day 724 Unit review	☐ Day 725 Romans 1:1-32	☐ Day 726 Doctrine: Divine opposition to sin	☐ Day 727 Romans 2:1-29	☐ Day 728 Sabbath rest	☐
105	☐ Day 729 Romans 3:1-31	☐ Day 730 Doctrine: Justification by Faith Alone	☐ Day 731 Romans 4:1-25	☐ Day 732 Psalm 32	☐ Day 733 Psalm 130	☐ Day 734 Psalm 143:1-12	☐ Day 735 Sabbath rest	☐
106	☐ Day 736 Romans 5:1-21	☐ Day 737 Doctrine: Union with Christ	☐ Day 738 Romans 6:1-23	☐ Day 739 Romans 7:1-25	☐ Day 740 Doctrine: Sanctification	☐ Day 741 Romans 8:1-39	☐ Day 742 Sabbath rest	☐
107	☐ Day 743 Romans 9:1-33	☐ Day 744 Romans 10:1-11:36	☐ Day 745 Psalm 19:1-6	☐ Day 746 Psalm 116	☐ Day 747 Psalm 117	☐ Day 748 Romans 12:1-13:14	☐ Day 749 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 21: Law, Gospel and Church Life: Galatians, Corinthians (begins Day 753)								
108	☐ Day 750 Romans 14:1-15:13	☐ Day 751 Romans 15:14-16:27	☐ Day 752 Unit review	☐ Day 753 Galatians 1:1-2:21	☐ Day 754 Doctrine: Adoption	☐ Day 755 Galatians 3:1-4:31	☐ Day 756 Sabbath rest	☐

WEEK	SUN	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	DONE
109	☐ Day 757 Galatians 5:1-6:18	☐ Day 758 1 Corinthians 1:1-2:16	☐ Day 759 1 Corinthians 3:1-4:21	☐ Day 760 Psalm 33	☐ Day 761 Psalm 62	☐ Day 762 1 Corinthians 5:1-7:40	☐ Day 763 Sabbath rest	☐
110	☐ Day 764 1 Corinthians 8:1-10:33	☐ Day 765 Doctrine: The Sacraments, The Lord's Supper	☐ Day 766 1 Corinthians 11:1-34	☐ Day 767 1 Corinthians 12:1-14:40	☐ Day 768 Doctrine: Spiritual Gifts and the Body of Christ	☐ Day 769 Psalm 111	☐ Day 770 Sabbath rest	☐
111	☐ Day 771 Psalm 112	☐ Day 772 Psalm 133	☐ Day 773 1 Corinthians 15:1-58	☐ Day 774 Doctrine: The Resurrection of Christ	☐ Day 775 Doctrine: The Resurrection of the Dead	☐ Day 776 1 Corinthians 16:1-24	☐ Day 777 Sabbath rest	☐
112	☐ Day 778 2 Corinthians 1:1-3:18	☐ Day 779 Doctrine: Death and the Intermediate State	☐ Day 780 2 Corinthians 4:1-5:21	☐ Day 781 2 Corinthians 6:1-9:15	☐ Day 782 2 Corinthians 10:1-13:14	☐ Day 783 Unit review	☐ Day 784 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 22: In Christ: Prison and Pastoral Epistles (begins this week)								
113	☐ Day 785 Ephesians 1:1-23	☐ Day 786 Doctrine: Election and Predestination	☐ Day 787 Doctrine: The Nature of the Church	☐ Day 788 Ephesians 2:1-3:21	☐ Day 789 Ephesians 4:1-32	☐ Day 790 Ephesians 5:1-6:24	☐ Day 791 Sabbath rest	☐
114	☐ Day 792 Psalm 68:1-20	☐ Day 793 Psalm 110:1-7	☐ Day 794 Philippians 1:1-2:30	☐ Day 795 Doctrine: Fully God and fully man	☐ Day 796 Philippians 3:1-4:23	☐ Day 797 Colossians 1:1-2:5	☐ Day 798 Sabbath rest	☐
115	☐ Day 799 Colossians 2:6-3:17	☐ Day 800 Colossians 3:18-4:18	☐ Day 801 Doctrine: Ordinary work as service to God	☐ Day 802 1 Thessalonians 1:1-3:13	☐ Day 803 Doctrine: The Return of Christ	☐ Day 804 1 Thessalonians 4:1-5:28	☐ Day 805 Sabbath rest	☐
116	☐ Day 806 Psalm 27	☐ Day 807 Psalm 138	☐ Day 808 Psalm 139:13-24	☐ Day 809 2 Thessalonians 1:1-3:18	☐ Day 810 1 Timothy 1:1-3:16	☐ Day 811 Doctrine: Church Government and Officers	☐ Day 812 Sabbath rest	☐
117	☐ Day 813 1 Timothy 4:1-6:21	☐ Day 814 2 Timothy 1:1-2:26	☐ Day 815 2 Timothy 3:1-4:22	☐ Day 816 Titus 1:1-3:15	☐ Day 817 Philemon 1:1-25	☐ Day 818 Unit review	☐ Day 819 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 23: The Better Covenant: Hebrews (begins this week)								
118	☐ Day 820 Hebrews 1:1-2:18	☐ Day 821 Hebrews 3:1-4:13	☐ Day 822 Hebrews 4:14-6:20	☐ Day 823 Psalm 95	☐ Day 824 Psalm 40:1-10	☐ Day 825 Psalm 110	☐ Day 826 Sabbath rest	☐
119	☐ Day 827 Hebrews 7:1-28	☐ Day 828 Hebrews 8:1-9:28	☐ Day 829 Hebrews 10:1-39	☐ Day 830 Doctrine: Covenanted community	☐ Day 831 Hebrews 11:1-40	☐ Day 832 Hebrews 12:1-29	☐ Day 833 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 24: Faith Lived Out: General Epistles (begins Day 837)								
120	☐ Day 834 Hebrews 13:1-25	☐ Day 835 Psalm 22	☐ Day 836 Unit review	☐ Day 837 James 1:1-27	☐ Day 838 James 2:1-26	☐ Day 839 Doctrine: What distinguishes saving faith	☐ Day 840 Sabbath rest	☐

WEEK	SUN	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	DONE
121	☐ Day 841 James 3:1-4:17	☐ Day 842 James 5:1-20	☐ Day 843 Psalm 12	☐ Day 844 Psalm 15	☐ Day 845 Psalm 24	☐ Day 846 1 Peter 1:1-2:12	☐ Day 847 Sabbath rest	☐
122	☐ Day 848 1 Peter 2:13-3:22	☐ Day 849 1 Peter 4:1-5:14	☐ Day 850 2 Peter 1:1-21	☐ Day 851 Doctrine: Why these 66 books	☐ Day 852 2 Peter 2:1-3:18	☐ Day 853 Psalm 34	☐ Day 854 Sabbath rest	☐
123	☐ Day 855 Psalm 118:1-18	☐ Day 856 Psalm 31:1-8	☐ Day 857 1 John 1:1-2:29	☐ Day 858 1 John 3:1-24	☐ Day 859 1 John 4:1-5:21	☐ Day 860 Doctrine: Perseverance and Assurance	☐ Day 861 Sabbath rest	☐
Unit 25: The New Covenant Consummated: Revelation (begins Day 866)								
124	☐ Day 862 2 John 1:1-13	☐ Day 863 3 John 1:1-14	☐ Day 864 Jude 1:1-25	☐ Day 865 Unit review	☐ Day 866 Revelation 1:1-20	☐ Day 867 Revelation 2:1-29	☐ Day 868 Sabbath rest	☐
125	☐ Day 869 Revelation 3:1-22	☐ Day 870 Psalm 1	☐ Day 871 Psalm 19	☐ Day 872 Psalm 29	☐ Day 873 Revelation 4:1-5:14	☐ Day 874 Revelation 6:1-17	☐ Day 875 Sabbath rest	☐
126	☐ Day 876 Revelation 7:1-8:13	☐ Day 877 Revelation 9:1-11:19	☐ Day 878 Psalm 141	☐ Day 879 Psalm 150	☐ Day 880 Psalm 148	☐ Day 881 Revelation 12:1-13:18	☐ Day 882 Sabbath rest	☐
127	☐ Day 883 Revelation 14:1-15:8	☐ Day 884 Psalm 2	☐ Day 885 Psalm 46	☐ Day 886 Psalm 93	☐ Day 887 Psalm 97	☐ Day 888 Revelation 16:1-21	☐ Day 889 Sabbath rest	☐
128	☐ Day 890 Revelation 17:1-18:24	☐ Day 891 Revelation 19:1-20:15	☐ Day 892 Doctrine: The Final Judgment	☐ Day 893 Revelation 21:1-22:5	☐ Day 894 Doctrine: The New Heavens and New Earth	☐ Day 895 Revelation 22:6-21	☐ Day 896 Sabbath rest	☐
129	☐ Day 897 Psalm 72:18-19	☐ Day 898 Psalm 150	☐ Day 899 Unit review	☐ Day 900 Sabbath rest				☐

REFERENCE

Glossary

Key terms used in the plan

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Apostle. One sent by Jesus with his authority. The term refers chiefly to the Twelve and to Paul, whose teaching is the foundation of the church.

Atonement. What God does through the death of Jesus to deal with sin and reconcile sinners to himself.

Canon. The collection of books recognized as Scripture. The Protestant Bible has 66 books, 39 in the Old Testament and 27 in the New.

Christ. A title meaning "anointed one," the Greek form of "Messiah." It names Jesus as the promised king and savior.

Church. The people God has gathered to himself through Christ. The word describes both the whole body of believers and a local gathering of them.

Covenant. A binding relationship God establishes with his people, with promises and obligations. The Bible tells its story through covenants with Noah, Abraham, Israel at Sinai, David, and the new covenant in Christ.

Creation. God bringing everything into being from nothing by his word, and the world he made and sustains.

Election. God's choice of a people for himself according to his own purpose and grace.

Eschatology. The study of last things: Christ's return, the resurrection, judgment, and the new creation.

Exile. The removal of Israel and Judah from the promised land to Assyria and Babylon, a result of covenant unfaithfulness. It also describes humanity's separation from God.

Exodus. God's rescue of Israel from slavery in Egypt. It becomes the pattern for later salvation in the Bible.

Faith. Trust in God and his promises, resting on what he has said and done, above all in Christ.

Fall. Adam and Eve's disobedience in Eden, through which sin and death entered the world.

Gospel. The good news that Jesus lived, died for sinners, rose again, and reigns, and that all who trust him are forgiven and made new.

Grace. God's undeserved kindness toward sinners.

Holiness. God's moral perfection and his separateness from all that is common or sinful. His people are called to be holy as well.

Incarnation. The Son of God taking on a full human nature in Jesus, while remaining fully God.

Inspiration. The conviction that Scripture is God-breathed. God spoke through human authors so that their writings are his word (2 Timothy 3:16).

Justification. God declaring sinners righteous in his sight because of Christ, received by faith alone.

Kingdom of God. God's rule and reign, present in Jesus and one day to be complete when he returns.

Law. God's instruction to Israel, especially in the first five books. It can also refer to the whole of the Old Testament.

Messiah. The promised anointed king from David's line. Christians confess that Jesus is that king.

Progressive covenantalism. A way of reading the Bible that sees God's covenants unfolding step by step, each building on the last, and all reaching their fulfillment in Christ and the new covenant.

Prophecy. God's word spoken through a prophet. It includes calls to repentance and promises of what is to come, not only prediction.

Propitiation. A sacrifice that turns away God's wrath. In the New Testament it describes Christ's death in the place of sinners.

Providence. God's continuing care for and rule over all things, working all events toward his purposes.

Redemption. Rescue by payment. The Bible uses it for God freeing his people from slavery and from sin.

Repentance. Turning from sin to God, with a change of mind, heart, and life.

Resurrection. Being raised bodily from death. Christ was raised first, and believers will follow when he returns.

Sabbath. A day of rest set apart to God, rooted in creation. It points to the rest God gives his people in Christ.

Sacrifice. An offering given to God. The Old Testament sacrifices pointed ahead to the once-for-all sacrifice of Christ.

Salvation. God's rescue of his people from sin, death, and judgment, and the new life he gives.

Sanctification. The lifelong work of the Holy Spirit making believers more like Christ.

Sin. Rebellion against God, whether in what we do, fail to do, or desire.

Trinity. The belief that there is one God who eternally exists as three persons, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Typology. The way persons, events, and institutions in the Old Testament foreshadow Christ and his work.

Wisdom. In the Bible, skill in living under God's rule, beginning with the fear of the Lord.

Worship. Honoring God for who he is, in praise, prayer, obedience, and all of life.

APPENDIX II

The Books of the Bible

Author, date, setting, theme, and a literary outline for each of the 66 books

Each entry gives a traditional, widely held starting point. Where scholars disagree about authorship or date, the entry says so briefly and does not try to settle the question. Dates are approximate. The outline follows the structure of the book itself and is not tied to the reading plan.

Contents

1 **Law: The Pentateuch**
Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy

2 **Old Testament: History**
Joshua, Judges, Ruth, 1 Samuel, 2 Samuel, 1 Kings, 2 Kings, 1 Chronicles, 2 Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther

3 **Old Testament: Wisdom and Poetry**
Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs

4 **Old Testament: The Major Prophets**
Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel

5 **Old Testament: The Minor Prophets**
Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi

6 **New Testament: Gospels and Acts**
Matthew, Mark, Luke, John, Acts

7 **New Testament: Paul's Letters**
Romans, 1 Corinthians, 2 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, 1 Thessalonians, 2 Thessalonians, 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, Titus, Philemon

8 **New Testament: General Letters and Revelation**
Hebrews, James, 1 Peter, 2 Peter, 1 John, 2 John, 3 John, Jude, Revelation

Law: The Pentateuch

Genesis

The book of beginnings

AUTHOR	Traditionally Moses.
DATE	Traditionally linked to the time of Moses, about 1400 to 1200 BC. The events span from creation to about 1800 BC.
SETTING	Written for Israel before entering the promised land. It tells where the world, sin, and the chosen family came from.
GENRE	Narrative, with genealogies and poetry.
THEME	God creates a good world, sin breaks it, and God begins a plan to bless all nations through Abraham's family.
KEY VERSE	Genesis 12:2-3
IN THIS PLAN	Units 1-3; Days 1-59 (32 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Genesis plants the promise of an offspring who will crush the serpent (3:15) and bless all nations through Abraham's line (12:3). Judah's line carries the scepter (49:10), and Isaac, Joseph, and the ram caught in the thicket all look ahead to the sacrifice and rescue God would provide.

HOW TO READ IT

Read Genesis as the foundation for everything after it. Watch for repeated patterns: a promise, a threat to the promise, and God's faithful rescue. The genealogies are not filler. They trace the line of promise from Adam through Abraham to the twelve tribes.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:3	Creation in six days and the Sabbath
2:4-4:26	Eden, the fall, and the first family
5:1-6:8	From Adam to Noah
6:9-9:29	Noah and the flood
10:1-11:26	The nations and Babel
11:27-25:18	Abraham
25:19-28:9	Isaac, Jacob, and Esau
28:10-36:43	Jacob
37:1-50:26	Joseph and the family in Egypt

Exodus

God rescues and dwells with his people

AUTHOR	Traditionally Moses.
DATE	Traditionally dated to the time of Moses. Scholars differ on the date of the exodus itself, often placed in the 1400s or 1200s BC.
SETTING	Israel in Egyptian slavery, then in the wilderness at Mount Sinai.
GENRE	Narrative and law.
THEME	God redeems Israel from slavery, makes a covenant with them at Sinai, and comes to live among them in the tabernacle.
KEY VERSE	Exodus 19:4-6
IN THIS PLAN	Units 5-6; Days 94-128 (22 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Moses the deliverer, the Passover lamb, the manna, the water from the rock, the tabernacle, and the priesthood all point to Jesus. John 1:14 says the Word "tabernacled" among us, and Paul calls Christ our Passover lamb (1 Corinthians 5:7).

HOW TO READ IT

Exodus has two halves: redemption (chapters 1-18) and covenant and worship (chapters 19-40). Notice that God rescues Israel before he gives the law. Obedience in this book always follows grace.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:25	Israel in Egypt and the birth of Moses
3:1-7:7	The call of Moses
7:8-11:10	The plagues
12:1-13:16	The Passover and the exodus
13:17-15:21	The crossing of the sea
15:22-18:27	From the sea to Sinai
19:1-24:18	The covenant at Sinai
25:1-31:18	Instructions for the tabernacle
32:1-34:35	The golden calf and the renewal of the covenant
35:1-40:38	Building the tabernacle

Leviticus

How a holy God lives among a sinful people

AUTHOR	Traditionally Moses.
DATE	Traditionally set at Mount Sinai in the time of Moses.
SETTING	Israel camped at Sinai, with the tabernacle newly built.
GENRE	Law, especially priestly and ritual instruction.
THEME	God is holy, sin is serious, and sacrifice and priesthood provide a way to approach him.
KEY VERSE	Leviticus 19:2
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 6; Days 129-143 (12 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Jesus is the sacrifice, the priest, and the tabernacle at once. The book of Hebrews explains that the offerings, the priesthood, and the Day of Atonement are shadows of what Christ accomplished once for all.

HOW TO READ IT

Do not read Leviticus as a list of random rules. Its question is how a holy God can live among sinners. Look for the repeated words “holy,” “clean,” “atonement,” and “forgiven.”

OUTLINE

1:1-7:38	The offerings
1:1-17	The burnt offering
8:1-10:20	The priesthood begins
8:1-36	The ordination of Aaron and his sons
9:1-24	The first sacrifices and the glory of the LORD
11:1-15:33	Clean and unclean
11:1-47	Clean and unclean animals
12:1-8	Childbirth
16:1-34	The Day of Atonement
16:1-10	Preparation and the two goats
16:11-28	The blood and the scapegoat
17:1-27:34	The call to holy living
17:1-16	The sanctity of blood
18:1-20:27	Sexual ethics, love of neighbor, and penalties

Numbers

A generation in the wilderness

AUTHOR	Traditionally Moses.
DATE	Traditionally covers about forty years after the exodus.
SETTING	Israel counted and organized at Sinai, then wandering until a new generation is ready to enter the land.
GENRE	Narrative, law, and census lists.
THEME	God stays faithful even when his people rebel, and he leads a new generation toward the promise.
KEY VERSE	Numbers 14:18
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 7; Days 150-173 (16 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The bronze serpent lifted up in the wilderness is a picture of Christ on the cross (John 3:14-15). The rock that gave water, the manna, and the cities of refuge all point forward, and Balaam's oracle speaks of a star and a scepter out of Israel (24:17).

HOW TO READ IT

Numbers alternates between narrative and lists. The census lists show God's careful care for his people. The stories show their repeated unbelief. Pay attention to how Moses intercedes and how God keeps his promise anyway.

OUTLINE

1:1-10:10	Preparing at Sinai
10:11-12:16	From Sinai to Paran
13:1-14:45	The twelve spies and the refusal to enter
15:1-19:22	Years of wandering
20:1-22:1	Toward Moab
22:2-25:18	Balaam and Baal of Peor
22:2-24:25	Balaam's oracles
26:1-36:13	A new generation
26:1-65	The second census

Deuteronomy

Moses' farewell sermons

AUTHOR	Traditionally Moses, with an account of his death added.
DATE	Traditionally set just before Israel enters the land, about 1400 to 1200 BC.
SETTING	Israel on the plains of Moab, with the Jordan ahead of them.
GENRE	Sermon and covenant renewal.
THEME	Love the Lord with all your heart, obey him, and remember what he has done.
KEY VERSE	Deuteronomy 6:4-5
IN THIS PLAN	Units 7 and 15; Days 174-599 (16 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Moses promises a prophet like himself (18:15), and the New Testament identifies him as Jesus. Jesus answered every temptation in the wilderness with words from this book, and Paul says Christ became a curse for us (Galatians 3:13, quoting Deuteronomy 21:23).

HOW TO READ IT

Deuteronomy is a sermon, not a law code. Notice the repeated words "remember," "hear," "today," and "love." The book's pattern follows ancient covenant documents: history, commands, blessings and curses, and witnesses.

OUTLINE

1:1-4:43	First address: look back
1:1-46	From Horeb to Kadesh
4:44-11:32	Second address: the call to love and obey
4:44-5:33	The Ten Commandments restated
12:1-26:19	The law applied
12:1-32	One place of worship
27:1-30:20	Covenant renewal
27:1-26	Ebal and Gerizim, and the curses
31:1-34:12	Moses' last days
31:1-30	Joshua commissioned
32:1-52	The Song of Moses

Old Testament: History

Joshua

Entering the promised land

AUTHOR Not named in the text. Tradition connects it with Joshua, with possible later editing.

DATE Events are often placed in the late 1400s or 1200s BC.

SETTING Israel under Joshua crosses the Jordan and takes possession of the land.

GENRE Historical narrative.

THEME God keeps his promise and gives Israel the land, and calls them to remain faithful.

KEY VERSE Joshua 21:45

IN THIS PLAN Unit 8; Days 200-214 (9 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Joshua's name is the same as Jesus in Hebrew. He leads God's people into the rest of the promised land, while Hebrews 4 teaches that Jesus leads his people into a greater rest. The commander of the LORD's army (5:13-15) is often seen as a preview of Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

Notice that the book stresses both God's gift of the land and the people's duty to obey. Read the conquest accounts alongside the repeated reminders that God was giving the land and judging the nations for their sin.

OUTLINE

1:1-5:12	Preparing and crossing the Jordan
1:1-18	Joshua commissioned
2:1-24	Rahab and the spies
5:13-12:24	The conquest
5:13-6:27	The commander of the LORD's army and Jericho
7:1-8:35	Achan's sin, Ai, and the renewal at Ebal
13:1-21:45	Dividing the land
13:1-33	Land east of the Jordan
14:1-15:63	Caleb and Judah
22:1-24:33	Final charges
22:1-34	The altar by the Jordan
23:1-16	Joshua's farewell

Judges

A cycle of sin, rescue, and decline

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Jewish tradition names Samuel.
DATE	Covers the period between Joshua and the monarchy, roughly 1200 to 1050 BC.
SETTING	Israel in the land without a king, surrounded by other peoples.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	Israel repeatedly turns from God, and God repeatedly raises up deliverers, yet the people grow worse and a king is needed.
KEY VERSE	Judges 21:25
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 8; Days 215-229 (9 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Each judge is a flawed rescuer, and the book keeps asking for a king who will be better. The true Judge and Deliverer is Jesus, who rescues once for all and reigns forever.

HOW TO READ IT

Read the book as a downward spiral: sin, oppression, cry for help, deliverance, and then relapse. The refrain "In those days there was no king in Israel" signals what the book is asking.

OUTLINE

1:1-3:6	Why the land was not fully taken
1:1-36	Incomplete conquest
2:1-5	The angel at Bochim
2:6-3:6	The cycle introduced
3:7-16:31	The judges
3:7-11	Othniel
3:12-30	Ehud
3:31	Shamgar
4:1-5:31	Deborah, Barak, and Jael
17:1-21:25	Israel's moral collapse
17:1-18:31	Micah's idol and the tribe of Dan
19:1-30	The Levite and his concubine
20:1-21:25	Civil war against Benjamin

Ruth

Faithful love in dark times

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Tradition has said Samuel.
DATE	Set in the time of the judges. Written probably after David's rise.
SETTING	A family from Bethlehem moves to Moab and returns.
GENRE	Short narrative.
THEME	God provides a redeemer for Naomi and Ruth, and through them prepares the way for David.
KEY VERSE	Ruth 4:14
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 8; Days 230-232 (2 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Boaz is a picture of the kinsman redeemer, one who buys back what was lost. Ruth, a foreigner, becomes the great-grandmother of David and appears in the family line of Jesus (Matthew 1:5).

HOW TO READ IT

Ruth is a short story with careful structure. Watch for the words "redeem," "kindness," and "refuge." Notice how ordinary acts of faithfulness carry God's larger plan.

OUTLINE

1:1-22	Loss in Moab and return to Bethlehem
1:1-5	Famine, exile, and three deaths
1:6-18	Ruth's pledge to Naomi
2:1-23	Ruth gleans in Boaz's field
2:1-7	Ruth meets Boaz
2:8-17	Boaz's kindness
3:1-18	Ruth at the threshing floor
3:1-5	Naomi's plan
3:6-15	Ruth and Boaz at midnight
4:1-22	Boaz redeems
4:1-12	The nearer kinsman and the gate
4:13-17	Marriage and the birth of Obed

1 Samuel

From judges to kings

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Often thought to rely on earlier records.
DATE	Covers about 1100 to 1010 BC. Final form is often dated after the kingdom divided.
SETTING	Israel moves from tribal rule under Eli and Samuel to the monarchy under Saul, with David rising.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	God gives Israel a king, rejects Saul for disobedience, and chooses David.
KEY VERSE	1 Samuel 16:7
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 9; Days 235-261 (11 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

David, the anointed shepherd king from Bethlehem, anticipates the greater Son of David. Hannah's song (2:1-10) speaks of God's "anointed" and foreshadows Mary's song in Luke 1.

HOW TO READ IT

The book turns on a contrast between outward and inward: Saul looks like a king, while David is a man after God's heart. Pay attention to who is listening to God and who is not.

OUTLINE

1:1-7:17	Eli and Samuel
1:1-2:11	Hannah's prayer and Samuel's birth
8:1-12:25	Israel asks for a king
8:1-22	The elders demand a king
9:1-10:27	Saul anointed
13:1-15:35	Saul's failures
13:1-22	The unlawful sacrifice
14:1-52	Jonathan's victory and Saul's rash oath
16:1-20:42	David's rise
16:1-23	David anointed and brought to Saul
17:1-58	David and Goliath
21:1-31:13	David on the run
21:1-22:23	Nob and the cave of Adullam
23:1-26:25	Saul pursues, and David spares him

2 Samuel

The reign of David

AUTHOR	Not named in the text.
DATE	Covers David's reign, about 1010 to 970 BC.
SETTING	David becomes king over Judah, then over all Israel, based in Jerusalem.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	God makes a covenant with David promising an everlasting kingdom, while David's sin brings trouble to his house.
KEY VERSE	2 Samuel 7:16
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 9; Days 262-288 (10 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

God's promise that David's throne will be established forever (7:12-16) is the center of the book. The New Testament announces Jesus as the Son of David whose kingdom has no end (Luke 1:32-33).

HOW TO READ IT

Read chapter 7 as the hinge of the book. Before it, David rises. After it, David's own sin shows that the promised king cannot be David himself.

OUTLINE

1:1-5:5	David becomes king
1:1-27	David's lament for Saul and Jonathan
2:1-4:12	Civil war between David and Saul's house
5:6-10:19	David's kingdom
5:6-25	Jerusalem and victory over the Philistines
6:1-23	The ark brought to Jerusalem
11:1-20:26	David's sin and its consequences
11:1-27	Bathsheba and Uriah
12:1-25	Nathan's rebuke and David's repentance
21:1-24:25	Appendix
21:1-22	Famine and the Philistine giants
22:1-51	David's song of deliverance

1 Kings

Glory and division

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Jewish tradition names Jeremiah.
DATE	Covers about 970 to 850 BC. Compiled during or after the Babylonian exile.
SETTING	Solomon builds the temple, the kingdom splits, and the prophets confront kings.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	Faithfulness to the covenant brings blessing and idolatry brings decline.
KEY VERSE	1 Kings 8:23
IN THIS PLAN	Units 9 and 11; Days 289-340 (9 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Solomon builds a temple, yet even he says that heaven cannot contain God (8:27). Jesus is greater than Solomon (Matthew 12:42), he is the true temple (John 2:19-21), and Elijah's ministry prepares for John the Baptist and Jesus.

HOW TO READ IT

Notice how the narrator evaluates each king by one test: did he follow the LORD wholeheartedly as David did? Watch also how the prophets stand against power.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:46	Solomon takes the throne
1:1-53	Adonijah's attempt and Solomon anointed
2:1-46	David's charge and Solomon's consolidation
3:1-11:43	Solomon's reign
3:1-28	The request for wisdom
4:1-34	Solomon's officials and wealth
12:1-16:34	The divided kingdom
12:1-33	Rehoboam and Jeroboam
13:1-14:20	The man of God from Judah
17:1-22:53	Elijah and the house of Ahab
17:1-24	The drought, the widow, and her son
18:1-46	Mount Carmel

2 Kings

The end of the kingdoms

AUTHOR	Not named in the text.
DATE	Covers about 850 to 560 BC.
SETTING	Israel falls to Assyria in 722 BC and Judah falls to Babylon in 586 BC.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	Persistent covenant unfaithfulness ends in exile, yet a hint of hope remains for David's line.
KEY VERSE	2 Kings 17:7
IN THIS PLAN	Units 11-13; Days 341-422 (11 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Elisha's miracles, including raising a child and feeding a crowd, prepare for the greater works of Jesus. Hezekiah and Josiah show reforming kings, but neither can finally save, and the book ends with a Davidic king still alive in exile, keeping hope open.

HOW TO READ IT

This book moves quickly from king to king. Keep an eye on the prophets, who explain why events happen, and on the final chapters, where the exile is described as the covenant curse come true.

OUTLINE

1:1-8:29	Elijah and Elisha
1:1-2:25	Elijah taken up and Elisha's mantle
3:1-27	War against Moab
9:1-17:41	Jehu to the fall of Israel
9:1-10:36	Jehu's revolt
11:1-12:21	Athaliah and Joash
13:1-14:29	Kings of Israel and Judah
18:1-25:30	Judah to the exile
18:1-20:21	Hezekiah and Isaiah
21:1-26	Manasseh and Amon
22:1-23:30	Josiah's reform

1 Chronicles

Israel's story retold for the returned exiles

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Tradition names Ezra.
DATE	Written after the exile, probably in the 400s or 300s BC.
SETTING	Written to people who had returned from exile and were rebuilding their identity.
GENRE	Genealogy and historical narrative.
THEME	God's covenant with David and the worship of the temple remain at the center of his people's hope.
KEY VERSE	1 Chronicles 17:14
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 522-533 (8 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The Chronicler holds the covenant with David at the center, a promise that the Messiah would come from David's line. The temple preparations point toward the final dwelling of God with his people.

HOW TO READ IT

Chronicles retells Israel's history from the viewpoint of the returned exiles. Read the opening genealogies as a statement that God's people have a name, a place, and a future.

OUTLINE

1:1-9:44	Genealogies from Adam to the exile
1:1-54	From Adam to Abraham's descendants
2:1-4:23	The tribe of Judah and the house of David
10:1-12:40	From Saul's death to David's rise
10:1-14	The death of Saul
11:1-12:40	David's mighty men and supporters
13:1-16:43	The ark brought to Jerusalem
13:1-14:17	The ark and the blessing on Obed-edom
15:1-16:43	The procession and the psalm of thanks
17:1-21:30	The Davidic covenant and wars
17:1-27	The promise of an eternal house
18:1-20:8	David's victories
22:1-29:30	Preparing for the temple
22:1-19	David's charge to Solomon
23:1-27:34	The Levites and the leaders

2 Chronicles

The kings of Judah and the temple

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Tradition names Ezra.
DATE	Written after the exile.
SETTING	Tells the story of Solomon and the kings of Judah, ending with the exile and a call to return.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	When the king and people seek the Lord, they find him, and when they forsake him they fall.
KEY VERSE	2 Chronicles 7:14
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 534-547 (9 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Solomon's temple foreshadows the true temple, Christ himself. The book ends with Cyrus's decree sending the exiles home, which points ahead to the greater return from exile that the prophets promised.

HOW TO READ IT

The Chronicler emphasizes that when kings seek the LORD, they prosper, and when they forsake him, they fall. Watch the stress on repentance and revival, especially under Hezekiah and Josiah.

OUTLINE

1:1-9:31	Solomon and the temple
1:1-17	Solomon's request for wisdom
10:1-28:27	The kings of Judah
10:1-12:16	Rehoboam and the division
13:1-16:14	Abijah and Asa
29:1-32:33	Hezekiah's revival
29:1-31:21	The temple cleansed and Passover kept
32:1-33	Sennacherib's invasion
33:1-36:23	The last kings and the exile
33:1-25	Manasseh and Amon
34:1-35:27	Josiah's reform and death

Ezra

Return and rebuilding

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Tradition names Ezra.
DATE	Covers about 538 to 458 BC.
SETTING	Jewish exiles return to Jerusalem under Persian rule and rebuild the temple.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	God keeps his promise to bring his people home, and his people must be rebuilt in obedience to the law.
KEY VERSE	Ezra 7:10
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 496-503 (4 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The return from exile and the rebuilding of the temple point to a greater restoration. Ezra's study and teaching of the law anticipate Christ, the final teacher of God's word.

HOW TO READ IT

Ezra covers two returns, one under Zerubbabel and one under Ezra himself. Notice the strong role of Scripture, prayer, and confession in rebuilding.

OUTLINE

1:1-6:22	The first return and the temple
1:1-11	Cyrus's decree and the return
2:1-70	The list of returning exiles
3:1-13	The altar and foundation laid
4:1-24	Opposition to the work
5:1-6:22	The temple finished and dedicated
7:1-10:44	Ezra's return and reform
7:1-28	Ezra's commission
8:1-36	The journey and the exiles who returned
9:1-15	Ezra's prayer about intermarriage
10:1-44	The people's response

Nehemiah

Rebuilding the wall

AUTHOR	Largely Nehemiah's own memoir.
DATE	Covers about 445 to 430 BC.
SETTING	Nehemiah, a cupbearer to the Persian king, returns to rebuild Jerusalem's walls.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	God's people rebuild by prayer, courage, and reading the law together.
KEY VERSE	Nehemiah 8:10
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 505-512 (5 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Nehemiah left a position of comfort to rebuild his people's city, and points to Christ, who left heaven to restore his people. The public reading of the law (chapter 8) points to the word of God that renews the heart.

HOW TO READ IT

Nehemiah is a leadership story. Notice how prayer and action go side by side, and how opposition grows as the work succeeds.

OUTLINE

1:1-7:73	Rebuilding the wall
1:1-11	Nehemiah's prayer
2:1-20	The king's permission and the night inspection
3:1-32	The builders listed
4:1-23	Opposition and the armed builders
5:1-19	Injustice among the people
6:1-19	The wall completed
7:1-73	The list of the people
8:1-10:39	Renewing the covenant
8:1-18	The reading of the law and the Feast of Booths
9:1-37	The prayer of confession
10:1-39	The pledge
11:1-13:31	Settling and reform
11:1-12:47	Resettlement and the dedication of the wall
13:1-31	Nehemiah's final reforms

Esther

God's hidden hand

AUTHOR	Not named in the text.
DATE	Set about 480 to 470 BC, in the reign of the Persian king Ahasuerus.
SETTING	Jews living in Persia, outside the land.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	God preserves his people through ordinary events, even when his name is not mentioned.
KEY VERSE	Esther 4:14
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 513-515 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

God preserves his people when they cannot rescue themselves, and the line of the Messiah survives the plot to destroy it. Mordecai and Esther are courageous mediators who point to the greater mediator who gave himself for his people.

HOW TO READ IT

God is never named in Esther, yet his providence is everywhere. Look for reversals: the gallows built for Mordecai, the king's sleepless night, and the feast Haman never enjoys.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:23	Esther becomes queen
1:1-22	Vashti removed
2:1-18	Esther chosen
3:1-5:14	Haman's plot
3:1-15	The decree to destroy the Jews
4:1-17	Mordecai's plea and Esther's decision
6:1-8:17	The reversal
6:1-14	Mordecai honored
7:1-10	Esther's second banquet and Haman's fall
9:1-10:3	Purim established
9:1-19	The Jews' deliverance
9:20-32	The feast of Purim

Old Testament: Wisdom and Poetry

Job

Suffering and the wisdom of God

AUTHOR Not named in the text.

DATE The setting is in the patriarchal age. The date of writing is uncertain.

SETTING A righteous man loses everything and wrestles with God and his friends.

GENRE Wisdom poetry in a narrative frame.

THEME Human understanding of suffering is limited, and God's wisdom and presence are enough.

KEY VERSE Job 19:25

IN THIS PLAN Unit 4; Days 64-86 (16 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Job longs for a mediator who could stand between him and God (9:33, 16:19-21, 19:25). Jesus is that mediator and redeemer, and he is also the righteous sufferer whose suffering was for others.

HOW TO READ IT

Job is poetry, so do not read the speeches as a debate with one right side. The friends say true things in the wrong way, and Job says bold things in pain. Notice that God never gives Job an explanation, but gives himself.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:13	The prologue
1:1-5	Job's character
3:1-31:40	Job and his friends
3:1-26	Job's lament
32:1-37:24	Elihu's speeches
32:1-33:33	Elihu begins
34:1-37:24	Elihu defends God's justice
38:1-42:6	The LORD answers
38:1-40:2	The first speech from the whirlwind
40:3-5	Job's first reply
42:7-17	The epilogue
42:7-9	The friends rebuked
42:10-17	Job restored

Psalms

The prayer book of Israel

AUTHOR	Many are attributed to David, with others to Asaph, the sons of Korah, Solomon, Moses, and unnamed authors.
DATE	Composed over many centuries, from the time of Moses to after the exile.
SETTING	Songs and prayers used in Israel's worship and personal life.
GENRE	Hebrew poetry: praise, lament, thanksgiving, wisdom, and royal psalms.
THEME	God is king, and his people can bring all their joy and sorrow to him.
KEY VERSE	Psalm 1:1-2
IN THIS PLAN	Scattered through the plan (235 days)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The psalms speak of the Messiah throughout: the anointed king (2), the suffering servant (22), the shepherd (23), the priest-king (110), and the stone the builders rejected (118). Jesus said that everything written about him in the Psalms had to be fulfilled (Luke 24:44).

HOW TO READ IT

Read one psalm at a time and ask what kind it is: praise, lament, thanksgiving, wisdom, or royal. Notice how laments usually move from complaint to trust. The psalms teach you how to pray when you do not know what to say.

OUTLINE

1-41	Book One
1-2	Introduction: the two ways and the anointed king
42-72	Book Two
42-49	Psalms of the sons of Korah
73-89	Book Three
73-83	Psalms of Asaph
90-106	Book Four
90-92	Moses, refuge, and the Sabbath song
107-150	Book Five
107	Give thanks to the LORD

Proverbs

Wisdom for daily life

AUTHOR	Largely Solomon, with sections credited to others such as Agur and Lemuel and to "the wise."
DATE	Collected over time, from about the 900s to the 700s BC or later.
SETTING	Instruction for the young and for those who lead, drawn from experience and the fear of the Lord.
GENRE	Wisdom sayings and poems.
THEME	The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom, and wise living follows from it.
KEY VERSE	Proverbs 9:10
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 10; Days 302-320 (13 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Wisdom calls aloud in the streets (1:20-33; 8:1-36), and the New Testament says that Christ is the wisdom of God (1 Corinthians 1:24, 30; Colossians 2:3). He is the one in whom all the treasures of wisdom are hidden.

HOW TO READ IT

Proverbs are general truths, not guaranteed promises. Read them slowly, a few at a time. Notice the contrast between the wise and the foolish, the righteous and the wicked, and the repeated call to fear the LORD.

OUTLINE

1:1-9:18	A father's appeal for wisdom
1:1-7	Purpose and motto
10:1-22:16	Proverbs of Solomon
10:1-15:33	Contrasts of the righteous and the wicked
22:17-24:34	Sayings of the wise
22:17-23:35	Thirty sayings
25:1-29:27	Hezekiah's collection
25:1-27:27	Kings, neighbors, and fools
30:1-31:31	Final words
30:1-33	The words of Agur

Ecclesiastes

Life under the sun

AUTHOR	The speaker calls himself "the Preacher" (Qoheleth). Tradition connects the book with Solomon.
DATE	Date is uncertain, with traditional dating in the 900s BC.
SETTING	A teacher reflects on work, pleasure, wealth, and death.
GENRE	Wisdom reflection.
THEME	Life without God is empty, but life received as his gift has meaning.
KEY VERSE	Ecclesiastes 12:13
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 10; Days 321-328 (5 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Qoheleth searches for meaning under the sun and finds that nothing under the sun satisfies. The book prepares for the one who comes from above the sun, Jesus Christ, who gives meaning that does not fade.

HOW TO READ IT

The refrain "vanity" means breath or vapor. Read the book as one argument, not as a list of separate sayings. The ending tells you how to read it: fear God and keep his commandments.

OUTLINE

1:1-11	The theme
1:1-3	The Preacher and the question
1:12-2:26	The search for meaning
1:12-18	Wisdom
3:1-4:16	Time and oppression
3:1-15	A time for everything
5:1-7:29	Living wisely
5:1-7	Worship
8:1-12:8	Uncertainty and death
8:1-17	Authority and what we cannot understand
12:9-14	Conclusion
12:9-12	The words of the wise
12:13-14	Fear God and keep his commandments

Song of Songs

The beauty of married love

AUTHOR	Attributed in the title to Solomon.
DATE	Traditionally dated to the 900s BC. Date of final form is debated.
SETTING	A woman and a man exchange love poems.
GENRE	Love poetry.
THEME	God made love and marriage good, and the church has long seen in it a picture of Christ and his people.
KEY VERSE	Song of Songs 8:6-7
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 10; Days 330-331 (2 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The church has long read this book as a picture of the love between Christ and his people, though it is first of all a celebration of human love in marriage. The New Testament calls the church the bride of Christ (Ephesians 5:31-32).

HOW TO READ IT

Read the book as a collection of lyrical scenes between a woman, a man, and a chorus of friends. Do not hurry. It is poetry about desire, and it teaches a right understanding of love, in the sense of "do not awaken love until it pleases" (2:7).

OUTLINE

1:1-2:7	Longing and delight
2:8-3:5	Spring and searching
3:6-5:1	The wedding
3:6-11	The royal procession
5:2-6:3	A dream of absence
5:2-8	He knocks and is gone
6:4-8:4	Renewed praise
6:4-7:9	The lover's praise
8:5-14	Love as strong as death
8:5-7	The seal of love

Old Testament: The Major Prophets

Isaiah

Judgment, comfort, and the coming servant

AUTHOR	Isaiah son of Amoz. Some scholars see later editing, while others hold to a single author.
DATE	Isaiah's ministry ran from about 740 to 700 BC.
SETTING	Judah under threat from Assyria, and later the promise of comfort for exiles.
GENRE	Prophecy and poetry.
THEME	God judges sin and promises salvation through a coming king and suffering servant.
KEY VERSE	Isaiah 53:5
IN THIS PLAN	Units 12 and 25; Days 380-894 (22 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Isaiah speaks of a virgin's son called Immanuel (7:14), a child who is Mighty God (9:6), a branch from Jesse (11:1), a servant who bears our sins (52:13-53:12), and a herald who brings good news (61:1). The New Testament quotes the book more than any other prophet.

HOW TO READ IT

Isaiah alternates between judgment and hope. Watch for the Holy One of Israel, a title that appears throughout. The book is a unified message of sin, judgment, comfort, and a new creation.

OUTLINE

1:1-12:6	Judgment and hope for Judah
1:1-31	The LORD's case against his people
13:1-27:13	Oracles against the nations
13:1-23:18	Babylon, Moab, Egypt, Tyre, and others
28:1-39:8	Trusting God, not nations
28:1-35:10	Woes and the coming king
40:1-55:13	Comfort and the servant
40:1-31	Comfort for God's people
56:1-66:24	Restoration and new creation
56:1-59:21	Justice and repentance

Jeremiah

The weeping prophet and the new covenant

AUTHOR	Jeremiah, with Baruch as scribe.
DATE	Ministry from about 627 to 580 BC.
SETTING	The last decades of Judah and the fall of Jerusalem to Babylon.
GENRE	Prophecy, poetry, and narrative.
THEME	God judges persistent sin yet promises a new covenant written on the heart.
KEY VERSE	Jeremiah 31:33
IN THIS PLAN	Units 3 and 13; Days 32-454 (19 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Jeremiah, the weeping prophet who was rejected by his people, points to Christ, who wept over Jerusalem. The promise of a new covenant (31:31-34) is fulfilled in Jesus, who said, "This cup is the new covenant in my blood" (Luke 22:20).

HOW TO READ IT

The book is not in chronological order. Read it as a collage of sermons, poems, stories, and visions. Notice Jeremiah's personal laments, and look for the promise of a new covenant, the central hope of the book.

OUTLINE

1:1-25:38	Warnings to Judah
1:1-19	Jeremiah's call
26:1-35:19	Conflict and promise
26:1-29:32	Prophets in conflict and the letter to the exiles
30:1-33:26	The book of consolation
36:1-45:5	Jeremiah and the fall
36:1-32	The scroll burned
37:1-39:18	The siege and the fall of Jerusalem
46:1-51:64	Oracles against the nations
46:1-49:39	Egypt, Philistia, Moab, Ammon, Edom, and others
50:1-51:64	Babylon
52:1-34	The fall of Jerusalem recalled

Lamentations

Grieving Jerusalem

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. Tradition names Jeremiah.
DATE	After the fall of Jerusalem in 586 BC.
SETTING	Mourning over the destroyed city.
GENRE	Poetry in five laments.
THEME	Honest grief before God, who remains faithful even in judgment.
KEY VERSE	Lamentations 3:22-23
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 13; Days 458-460 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The grieving of Jerusalem points to Jesus, the man of sorrows, who wept over the city and who bore the full weight of judgment. The hope in 3:22-23, that the LORD's mercies are new every morning, is fulfilled in him.

HOW TO READ IT

Each chapter is an acrostic poem built on the Hebrew alphabet, and the third chapter is the center of the book. Read it as a model for honest grief that does not let go of God.

OUTLINE

1:1-22	Jerusalem desolate
1:1-11	The city mourns
2:1-22	The LORD's anger
2:1-10	The LORD has destroyed
3:1-66	Hope in the LORD's mercy
3:1-20	The man who has seen affliction
4:1-22	The siege remembered
4:1-12	The city's ruin
4:13-22	Judgment on prophets and priests
5:1-22	A prayer for restoration
5:1-18	Remember what has come upon us
5:19-22	Restore us, O LORD

Ezekiel

Visions of glory and renewal

AUTHOR	Ezekiel, a priest living among the exiles.
DATE	Ministry from about 593 to 571 BC.
SETTING	The exiles in Babylon, before and after Jerusalem's fall.
GENRE	Prophecy, visions, and symbolic acts.
THEME	God's glory departs from the temple because of sin, and he promises a new heart and a restored people.
KEY VERSE	Ezekiel 36:26
IN THIS PLAN	Units 13 and 17; Days 461-638 (16 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The good shepherd of chapter 34, the new heart and spirit of chapter 36, and the river from the temple in chapter 47 all point to Christ. Jesus calls himself the good shepherd, and he gives living water.

HOW TO READ IT

Ezekiel is full of visions and symbolic acts. Watch for the repeated phrase "then they will know that I am the LORD." The book moves from the departure of God's glory to its return.

OUTLINE

1:1-3:27	Ezekiel's call
1:1-28	The vision of the glory of the LORD
4:1-24:27	Judgment on Jerusalem
4:1-7:27	Signs and oracles of judgment
25:1-32:32	Judgment on the nations
25:1-28:26	Ammon, Moab, Tyre, and Sidon
29:1-32:32	Egypt
33:1-39:29	Restoration
33:1-33	The watchman renewed
34:1-31	The shepherds and the good shepherd
40:1-48:35	The new temple
40:1-43:27	The vision of the new temple and the return of the glory
44:1-46:24	Worship and the prince

Daniel

Faithful in a foreign land

AUTHOR	Traditionally Daniel. Some scholars date the book later, so readers differ on its date.
DATE	Set in the 500s BC during the exile and Persian rule.
SETTING	Jewish exiles serve in Babylonian and Persian courts.
GENRE	Narrative and apocalyptic visions.
THEME	God rules over every empire, and his kingdom will outlast them all.
KEY VERSE	Daniel 7:13-14
IN THIS PLAN	Units 13 and 21; Days 486-775 (7 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The fourth man in the fiery furnace and the "son of man" coming on the clouds (7:13-14) point to Christ. Jesus took the title Son of Man from Daniel and is the king whose kingdom will never end.

HOW TO READ IT

Daniel has two halves: stories (1-6) and visions (7-12). The stories show faithfulness in a foreign court. The visions show God ruling over history. Note that the book is written partly in Hebrew and partly in Aramaic.

OUTLINE

1:1-21	Daniel and his friends in Babylon
2:1-49	Nebuchadnezzar's dream
3:1-30	The fiery furnace
3:1-18	The golden image and the refusal
4:1-37	Nebuchadnezzar humbled
4:1-27	The dream of the tree
5:1-31	The writing on the wall
6:1-28	Daniel in the lions' den
7:1-28	Four beasts and the Son of Man
7:1-14	The vision
8:1-12:13	Visions of the future
8:1-27	The ram and the goat

Old Testament: The Minor Prophets

Hosea

A faithful God and an unfaithful people

AUTHOR	Hosea.
DATE	Ministry in the northern kingdom, about 750 to 722 BC.
SETTING	Israel falls into idolatry. Hosea's marriage becomes a picture of God's love.
GENRE	Prophecy.
THEME	God loves his people even when they are unfaithful and calls them back.
KEY VERSE	Hosea 6:6
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 11; Days 363-367 (4 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

God's patient love for an unfaithful bride, shown in Hosea's marriage, points to Christ and his church. Matthew 2:15 applies "out of Egypt I called my son" to Jesus, and Paul quotes Hosea about Gentiles becoming "my people" (Romans 9:25).

HOW TO READ IT

Hosea is a book of painful love. Watch for the shifts between accusation and tenderness. The names of Hosea's children are messages, and they are later reversed.

OUTLINE

1:1-3:5	Hosea's marriage
1:1-2:1	Gomer and the three children
2:2-23	The unfaithful wife and the restored bride
3:1-5	Hosea buys Gomer back
4:1-14:9	God's case against Israel
4:1-6:3	No knowledge of God
6:4-11:11	Israel's unfaithfulness and God's compassion
11:1-11	The father's love
12:1-14:9	A call to return

Joel

The day of the Lord

AUTHOR	Joel.
DATE	Date is debated, with proposals from the 800s to the 400s BC.
SETTING	A locust plague becomes a picture of coming judgment.
GENRE	Prophecy.
THEME	Return to the Lord, and he will pour out his Spirit.
KEY VERSE	Joel 2:28
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 548-549 (2 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Joel promises that the Spirit will be poured out on all flesh (2:28-32). Peter says this was fulfilled at Pentecost (Acts 2:16-21). The day of the LORD finds its center in Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

Joel uses a plague of locusts as a picture of a greater judgment. Read it as a call to repent, with the promise that God will restore and pour out his Spirit.

OUTLINE

1:1-20	The locust plague
1:1-12	The land devastated
1:13-20	A call to lament
2:1-17	The day of the LORD
2:1-11	An army of judgment
2:12-17	Return to me with all your heart
2:18-27	The LORD's answer
2:18-27	Restoration of the land
2:28-3:21	The Spirit and the final judgment
2:28-32	The Spirit poured out
3:1-16	The nations judged
3:17-21	The LORD dwells in Zion

Amos

Justice rolling like water

AUTHOR	Amos, a herdsman from Tekoa.
DATE	About 760 to 750 BC.
SETTING	Prosperous Israel ignores the poor and worships falsely.
GENRE	Prophecy.
THEME	God demands justice and true worship, and promises to restore David's house.
KEY VERSE	Amos 5:24
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 11; Days 354-356 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Amos looks forward to restoring David's fallen tent (9:11-12), which James quotes at the council in Jerusalem to explain the Gentiles' inclusion (Acts 15:15-18). Christ is the one who fulfills justice.

HOW TO READ IT

Amos is a shepherd from Judah speaking to the north. Notice how he begins with judgment on the neighbors and then turns to Israel itself. The book ends in hope.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:16	Judgment on the nations and Israel
1:1-2	The LORD roars
1:3-2:5	Syria, Philistia, Tyre, Edom, Ammon, Moab, and Judah
2:6-16	Israel
3:1-6:14	Sermons against Israel
3:1-15	Chosen and accountable
4:1-13	Failure to return
5:1-27	A lament and a call to seek the LORD
6:1-14	Woe to those at ease
7:1-9:10	Visions of judgment
7:1-9	Locusts, fire, and the plumb line
7:10-17	Amos and Amaziah
8:1-14	The basket of summer fruit
9:1-10	The LORD beside the altar
9:11-15	Restoration
9:11-15	David's tent rebuilt

Obadiah

Judgment on Edom

AUTHOR	Obadiah.
DATE	Probably after the fall of Jerusalem in 586 BC, though debated.
SETTING	Edom gloated over Judah's fall.
GENRE	Prophecy, the shortest book of the Old Testament.
THEME	Pride falls, and the Lord's kingdom will come.
KEY VERSE	Obadiah 1:15
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Day 550

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The final verse, "the kingdom shall be the LORD's," points forward to the kingdom of Christ. Edom's pride is set against the humility of the Messiah.

HOW TO READ IT

Obadiah is one chapter and is best read in one sitting. Notice the theme of reversal: Edom's pride is brought down, and Israel's lowly remnant is lifted up.

OUTLINE

1-4	The announcement
1	The vision and the call to war
2-4	Edom brought down
5-9	The completeness of the judgment
5-7	Looters and betrayal
8-9	The wise and mighty destroyed
10-14	The reason for judgment
10-11	Violence and standing aside
12-14	Do not gloat
15-18	The day of the LORD
15-16	As you did, it shall be done to you
17-18	Zion and the house of Jacob
19-21	The kingdom shall be the LORD's
19-20	The land possessed
21	Saviors on Mount Zion

Jonah

A reluctant prophet and a merciful God

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. The prophet Jonah appears in 2 Kings 14.
DATE	Set in the 700s BC.
SETTING	Jonah is sent to Nineveh, the capital of Assyria.
GENRE	Narrative.
THEME	God's mercy reaches even Israel's enemies.
KEY VERSE	Jonah 4:2
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 11; Days 370-372 (2 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Jesus called Jonah's three days in the fish a sign of his own death and resurrection (Matthew 12:39-41). He said that one greater than Jonah is here.

HOW TO READ IT

Jonah is a story with a surprise ending. Notice that the question at the end is addressed to Jonah, and the book leaves it open for the reader to answer.

OUTLINE

1:1-17	Jonah flees
1:1-3	The call and the flight
1:4-16	The storm and the sailors
1:17	The great fish
2:1-10	Jonah's prayer
2:1-9	Prayer from the fish
2:10	Jonah delivered
3:1-10	Nineveh repents
3:1-4	The second call
3:5-10	The city turns and God relents
4:1-11	Jonah's anger and God's question
4:1-5	Jonah complains
4:6-11	The plant and the question

Micah

Justice, mercy, and a ruler from Bethlehem

AUTHOR	Micah.
DATE	About 735 to 700 BC.
SETTING	Judah and Israel under Assyrian threat.
GENRE	Prophecy.
THEME	God judges injustice and promises a shepherd king from Bethlehem.
KEY VERSE	Micah 6:8
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 11; Days 373-375 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Micah 5:2 names Bethlehem as the birthplace of the ruler whose origin is from of old, and the chief priests quoted it to Herod (Matthew 2:5-6). The shepherd king is Jesus.

HOW TO READ IT

Micah has three cycles, each beginning with "Hear" and each moving from judgment to hope. Notice the famous summary in 6:8.

OUTLINE

1:1-3:12	First cycle: judgment
1:1-16	The LORD comes down
2:1-13	Greed and the remnant
3:1-12	Rulers and prophets rebuked
4:1-5:15	Second cycle: hope
4:1-8	The mountain of the LORD
4:9-5:1	Exile and rescue
5:2-15	The ruler from Bethlehem
6:1-7:20	Third cycle: God's case and pardon
6:1-8	What does the LORD require
6:9-7:6	Judgment and lament
7:7-20	Who is a God like you

Nahum

The fall of Nineveh

AUTHOR	Nahum.
DATE	Probably between about 663 and 612 BC.
SETTING	Nineveh, the Assyrian capital, will fall.
GENRE	Prophecy and poetry.
THEME	God is slow to anger but will judge oppression.
KEY VERSE	Nahum 1:7
IN THIS PLAN	Units 12 and 20; Days 417-726 (2 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Nahum 1:15 speaks of the messenger who brings good news and announces peace, which is quoted by Paul about the gospel (Romans 10:15). The justice of God against oppression is satisfied fully in Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

Nahum is a poem about the end of an empire. Read it as the other side of Jonah: Nineveh repented once, but later returned to cruelty.

OUTLINE

1:1-15	The LORD's power
1:1-8	The LORD is a jealous and avenging God
1:9-15	The end of the plot and good news for Judah
2:1-13	The fall described
2:1-10	The attack on the city
2:11-13	The lion's den
3:1-19	Why Nineveh falls
3:1-7	Woe to the bloody city
3:8-19	No escape

Habakkuk

Questions and faith

AUTHOR Habakkuk.

DATE Probably about 610 to 600 BC.

SETTING Habakkuk asks why God allows injustice in Judah and then why he uses Babylon.

GENRE Prophecy, dialogue, and prayer.

THEME The righteous live by faith, trusting God even when circumstances are hard.

KEY VERSE Habakkuk 2:4

IN THIS PLAN Unit 12; Day 418

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Habakkuk 2:4, "the righteous shall live by his faith," is quoted three times in the New Testament (Romans 1:17; Galatians 3:11; Hebrews 10:38). The just live by faith in Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

Habakkuk is a conversation between the prophet and God. Follow the sequence: complaint, answer, complaint, answer, and then a prayer of trust.

OUTLINE

1:1-11	First complaint and answer
1:1-4	How long, O LORD
1:5-11	I am doing a work: Babylon
1:12-2:20	Second complaint and answer
1:12-2:1	Why are you silent
2:2-5	The righteous live by faith
2:6-20	Five woes
3:1-19	Habakkuk's prayer
3:1-15	The LORD comes in glory
3:16-19	Though the fig tree should not blossom

Zephaniah

The day of the Lord and a restored remnant

AUTHOR	Zephaniah.
DATE	Probably about 640 to 620 BC, in the reign of Josiah.
SETTING	Judah faces judgment, with a call to seek the Lord.
GENRE	Prophecy.
THEME	God judges the proud and gathers the humble, rejoicing over them.
KEY VERSE	Zephaniah 3:17
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 12; Day 419

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The promise that the LORD will rejoice over his people with singing (3:17) is realized in Christ, who gathers the scattered and rejoices over them.

HOW TO READ IT

Zephaniah begins with total judgment and ends with joyful singing. Notice how "the day of the LORD" is dark for the proud and bright for the humble.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:3	Judgment and a call to seek the LORD
1:1-6	Judgment on the whole earth
1:7-18	The day of the LORD
2:1-3	Seek the LORD
2:4-15	Judgment on the nations
2:4-7	Philistia
2:8-15	Moab, Ammon, Cush, and Assyria
3:1-20	Jerusalem and restoration
3:1-8	The rebellious city
3:9-13	A purified remnant
3:14-20	Sing, O daughter of Zion

Haggai

Rebuild the house

AUTHOR	Haggai.
DATE	About 520 BC.
SETTING	Returned exiles have neglected the temple.
GENRE	Prophecy.
THEME	Put God first, and he will be with his people.
KEY VERSE	Haggai 2:9
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Day 555

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The promise that the glory of the latter house will be greater than the former (2:9) is fulfilled when Christ comes to the temple. Zerubbabel, a descendant of David, is a sign of the coming king.

HOW TO READ IT

Haggai has four short messages, each dated precisely. Watch how God moves the people from self-concern to obedience and from discouragement to hope.

OUTLINE

1:1-15	The first message: rebuild the temple
1:1-11	Consider your ways
1:12-15	The people obey
2:1-9	The second message: the coming glory
2:1-5	Take courage
2:6-9	The latter glory
2:10-19	The third message: blessing
2:10-19	From this day I will bless you
2:20-23	The fourth message: Zerubbabel
2:20-23	The LORD's signet ring

Zechariah

Visions of hope for the returned exiles

AUTHOR	Zechariah. Some scholars see a different author for the later chapters.
DATE	Begins about 520 BC.
SETTING	Returned exiles are encouraged to finish the temple.
GENRE	Prophecy and visions.
THEME	God will cleanse his people and send a humble king.
KEY VERSE	Zechariah 9:9
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 556-561 (5 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Zechariah 9:9, the king who comes humble and riding on a donkey, is fulfilled at the triumphal entry. The pierced one (12:10), the shepherd who is struck (13:7), and the fountain for sin (13:1) all point to Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

Zechariah is full of visions and symbols. Read the visions in chapters 1 to 6 as encouragement for builders, and chapters 9 to 14 as oracles about the coming king.

OUTLINE

1:1-6	A call to return
1:1-6	Return to me
1:7-6:15	Eight night visions
1:7-17	The horsemen
1:18-2:13	The horns and the measuring line
3:1-10	Joshua the high priest cleansed
7:1-8:23	Questions about fasting
7:1-14	True fasting
8:1-23	Jerusalem restored
9:1-14:21	Oracles of the coming king
9:1-17	The humble king
10:1-11:17	The shepherds
12:1-13:9	The pierced one and the cleansing fountain

Malachi

The last word of the Old Testament

AUTHOR	Malachi.
DATE	Probably about 450 to 400 BC.
SETTING	The returned community has grown lax in worship and covenant faithfulness.
GENRE	Prophecy in a dialogue style.
THEME	God loves his people and calls them to faithful worship, with a messenger promised before the day of the Lord.
KEY VERSE	Malachi 3:1
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 14; Days 562-563 (2 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Malachi promises a messenger who will prepare the way (3:1) and the sun of righteousness who rises with healing (4:2). The New Testament identifies John the Baptist as the messenger and Jesus as the LORD who comes to his temple.

HOW TO READ IT

Malachi is a series of questions and answers. God makes a claim, the people ask "How?" and God replies. Read it as a covenant lawsuit in dialogue form.

OUTLINE

1:1-5	God's love for Israel
1:1-5	I have loved you
1:6-2:9	Corrupt priests
1:6-14	Blemished offerings
2:1-9	A warning to the priests
2:10-16	Faithlessness
2:10-16	Breaking the covenant in marriage
2:17-3:5	The coming messenger
2:17-3:5	Where is the God of justice
3:6-4:6	Return to me
3:6-12	Robbing God
3:13-4:3	The book of remembrance and the day
4:4-6	Remember the law and Elijah

New Testament: Gospels and Acts

Matthew

Jesus, the promised king

AUTHOR	Traditionally the apostle Matthew. The book itself is anonymous.
DATE	Often dated between about AD 60 and 85.
SETTING	Written with a strong Jewish background, showing Jesus as the fulfillment of the Old Testament.
GENRE	Gospel: a narrative of Jesus' life with five major teaching sections.
THEME	Jesus is the Messiah and king who brings the kingdom of heaven.
KEY VERSE	Matthew 16:16
IN THIS PLAN	Units 5, 15, 21, 22 and 25; Days 111-892 (29 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Matthew presents Jesus as the promised Messiah, the son of David and son of Abraham, who fulfills the Law and the Prophets. He is Immanuel, "God with us" (1:23), and he ends with the promise, "I am with you always" (28:20).

HOW TO READ IT

Matthew gathers Jesus' teaching into five great discourses, each ending with a phrase such as "when Jesus had finished these sayings." Watch for the phrase "this was to fulfill what was spoken by the prophet."

OUTLINE

1:1-4:11	Birth and preparation
4:12-7:29	The kingdom proclaimed
8:1-10:42	The kingdom in power
11:1-13:52	Responses to the kingdom
11:1-12:50	Rejection and growing opposition
13:53-18:35	The church and the cross approaching
13:53-16:12	Withdrawal and feeding the multitudes
19:1-25:46	Jerusalem
19:1-20:34	Journey to Jerusalem
26:1-28:20	Passion and resurrection
26:1-27:66	Last supper, trial, and crucifixion

Mark

Jesus, the suffering servant

AUTHOR	Traditionally John Mark, associated with Peter. The book itself is anonymous.
DATE	Often dated between about AD 55 and 70.
SETTING	Written in a brisk style, likely for a wider audience, including Gentile readers.
GENRE	Gospel.
THEME	Jesus is the Son of God who came to serve and give his life as a ransom.
KEY VERSE	Mark 10:45
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 18; Days 666-685 (14 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Mark moves quickly to show Jesus as the Son of God who came to serve and to give his life as a ransom for many (10:45). The centurion at the cross is the first human to confess him as the Son of God (15:39).

HOW TO READ IT

Mark is the shortest Gospel and the most action-driven. Watch for the word "immediately." Notice how often Jesus tells people not to tell, and how the disciples struggle to understand.

OUTLINE

1:1-13	The beginning
1:1-8	John the Baptist
1:14-8:26	Ministry in Galilee
1:14-3:12	Authority and early opposition
8:27-10:52	The way of the cross
8:27-9:29	Peter's confession and the transfiguration
9:30-10:52	Teaching on discipleship
11:1-13:37	Jerusalem
11:1-12:44	Entry, temple, and controversies
13:1-37	The Olivet discourse
14:1-16:8	Passion and resurrection
14:1-72	The Last Supper, Gethsemane, and trial
15:1-47	The crucifixion and burial

Luke

Jesus, savior for all people

AUTHOR	Traditionally Luke, a physician and companion of Paul. The book itself is anonymous.
DATE	Often dated between about AD 60 and 85.
SETTING	Addressed to Theophilus, and first volume of a two-part work with Acts.
GENRE	Gospel, with careful historical narrative.
THEME	Jesus came to seek and to save the lost, including the poor and outsiders.
KEY VERSE	Luke 19:10
IN THIS PLAN	Units 15, 16, 18 and 21; Days 571-779 (21 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Luke shows Jesus as the Savior of the world who seeks and saves the lost (19:10). Only Luke includes the parables of the good Samaritan, the lost son, and the rich man and Lazarus, and he ends on the road to Emmaus, where Jesus explains the Scriptures about himself.

HOW TO READ IT

Luke is the first of two volumes, with Acts. Watch for his interest in the poor, women, outsiders, prayer, and the Holy Spirit. Notice the long travel section from 9:51.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:52	Birth and childhood
3:1-4:13	Preparation
3:1-38	John, baptism, and genealogy
4:14-9:50	Ministry in Galilee
4:14-5:39	Nazareth and the first disciples
9:51-19:27	Journey to Jerusalem
9:51-13:21	Teaching and mission
19:28-23:56	Final week and cross
19:28-21:38	Entry and teaching
24:1-53	Resurrection and ascension
24:1-35	The empty tomb and the Emmaus road

John

Jesus, the Word made flesh

AUTHOR	Traditionally the apostle John. The book itself does not name its author.
DATE	Often dated between about AD 80 and 95.
SETTING	Selected signs and teachings written so that readers believe.
GENRE	Gospel, with a different structure from Matthew, Mark, and Luke.
THEME	Jesus is the eternal Son of God, and eternal life comes through believing in him.
KEY VERSE	John 20:31
IN THIS PLAN	Units 17, 19, 21 and 24; Days 634-860 (22 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

John begins with the Word who is God and became flesh, and ends so that readers may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God. Seven "I am" sayings and seven signs show who he is.

HOW TO READ IT

John is built around signs, long discourses, and the "hour" of the cross. Read it slowly. Notice repeated words like "believe," "life," "light," "truth," and "abide."

OUTLINE

1:1-18	The prologue
1:1-5	The Word was God
1:6-18	The Word became flesh
1:19-12:50	The book of signs
1:19-2:12	The first disciples and water into wine
2:13-4:54	Temple, Nicodemus, and the woman at the well
13:1-17:26	The farewell
13:1-38	Footwashing and the new commandment
14:1-16:33	The way, the Spirit, and the vine
18:1-20:31	Passion and resurrection
18:1-19:42	Arrest, trial, and crucifixion
20:1-31	The empty tomb and Thomas
21:1-25	Epilogue
21:1-25	Breakfast by the sea and Peter restored

Acts

The church begins and spreads

AUTHOR	Traditionally Luke, the author of the third Gospel.
DATE	Covers about AD 30 to 62. Often dated to the 60s or later.
SETTING	The early church spreads from Jerusalem to Rome.
GENRE	Historical narrative.
THEME	The risen Christ builds his church through the Holy Spirit, taking the gospel to all nations.
KEY VERSE	Acts 1:8
IN THIS PLAN	Units 15, 19, 22 and 23; Days 600-830 (26 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Acts continues what Jesus began to do and teach (1:1), now through the Spirit and the church. Luke shows the risen Christ ruling from heaven, adding to his church, and bringing the gospel to every nation.

HOW TO READ IT

Acts follows the plan of 1:8: Jerusalem, Judea and Samaria, and the ends of the earth. Watch for summary statements such as "the word of God continued to increase" that mark each stage.

OUTLINE

1:1-8:3	Witness in Jerusalem
1:1-26	The ascension and the replacement of Judas
8:4-12:25	Judea, Samaria, and the first Gentiles
8:4-40	Philip in Samaria and the Ethiopian
13:1-15:35	The first journey and the Jerusalem council
13:1-14:28	Paul and Barnabas sent out
15:1-35	The Jerusalem council
15:36-21:16	Paul's later journeys
15:36-18:22	Macedonia, Athens, and Corinth
18:23-20:38	Ephesus and the farewell
21:17-28:31	Arrest and Rome
21:17-23:35	Arrest in Jerusalem
24:1-26:32	Before Felix, Festus, and Agrippa

New Testament: Paul's Letters

Romans

The gospel explained

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 57.
SETTING	Written to believers in Rome, a church Paul had not yet visited.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Righteousness from God comes by faith in Christ to Jew and Gentile alike.
KEY VERSE	Romans 1:16-17
IN THIS PLAN	Units 1, 4, 5, 12, 15, 19, 20, 21, 22 and 24; Days 6-860 (28 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Romans shows that God's righteousness is revealed in Christ, who was delivered up for our trespasses and raised for our justification (4:25). Christ is the second Adam (5:12-21), the end of the law for righteousness (10:4), and the one in whom there is no condemnation (8:1).

HOW TO READ IT

Romans is a tightly argued letter. Read it in large sections. Chapters 1 to 8 explain the gospel, 9 to 11 explain God's plan for Israel, and 12 to 16 explain how to live it.

OUTLINE

1:1-17	Introduction
1:18-3:20	All are guilty
3:21-5:21	Justification by faith
3:21-31	Righteousness through faith in Christ
6:1-8:39	New life in Christ
6:1-23	Dead to sin, alive to God
9:1-11:36	God's plan for Israel
9:1-29	God's sovereign choice
12:1-15:13	Living the gospel
12:1-21	Living sacrifices
15:14-16:27	Paul's plans and greetings
15:14-33	Paul's ministry

1 Corinthians

Order and love in a divided church

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 53 to 55.
SETTING	Written to the church in Corinth, which faced division and moral problems.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	The cross reshapes church life, and love is the way of Christ's people.
KEY VERSE	1 Corinthians 15:3-4
IN THIS PLAN	Units 18, 21 and 22; Days 667-801 (14 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that Christ crucified is the power and wisdom of God (1:23-24), that Christ is our Passover lamb (5:7), and that he has been raised as the firstfruits of those who have died (15:20).

HOW TO READ IT

1 Corinthians answers specific questions and problems in a divided church. Notice how Paul returns to the cross in each section, and how chapter 13 on love sits in the middle of the discussion of gifts.

OUTLINE

1:1-4:21	Division and the cross
1:1-17	Greeting and appeal for unity
5:1-7:40	Moral questions
5:1-6:20	Immorality and lawsuits
8:1-11:1	Food offered to idols
8:1-13	Knowledge and love
11:2-14:40	Worship and gifts
11:2-34	Order in worship and the Lord's Supper
12:1-31	Spiritual gifts and one body
15:1-58	The resurrection
15:1-11	The gospel of first importance
15:12-34	If Christ is not raised
16:1-24	The collection and closing

2 Corinthians

Weakness and ministry

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 55 to 56.
SETTING	Paul defends his ministry and urges generosity and reconciliation.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	God's power appears in weakness, and the new covenant ministry gives new life.
KEY VERSE	2 Corinthians 12:9
IN THIS PLAN	Units 4, 15, 19, 21 and 25; Days 87-892 (9 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that the one who knew no sin became sin for us (5:21), that Christ's grace was sufficient in weakness (12:9), and that God has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Christ (4:6).

HOW TO READ IT

2 Corinthians is Paul's most personal letter. Notice how he defends his ministry not by showing strength, but by showing weakness, and how he ties his suffering to the cross.

OUTLINE

1:1-7:16	Paul's ministry
1:1-2:17	Comfort and the change of plans
3:1-4:6	The new covenant ministry
4:7-5:21	Treasure in jars of clay and reconciliation
6:1-7:16	Open hearts and godly grief
8:1-9:15	The collection for Jerusalem
8:1-24	The example of the Macedonians
9:1-15	God loves a cheerful giver
10:1-13:14	Paul defends his apostleship
10:1-18	Paul's authority
11:1-12:10	The fool's speech and the thorn in the flesh
12:11-13:14	Final warnings and greetings

Galatians

Freedom in the gospel

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Dated between about AD 48 and 55, depending on where the churches were located.
SETTING	Paul writes to churches being pressured to add the law to the gospel.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	We are justified by faith in Christ, not by works of the law.
KEY VERSE	Galatians 2:20
IN THIS PLAN	Units 20-21; Days 730-757 (6 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us (3:13), and that he now lives in believers (2:20). The central message is that Christ alone is enough.

HOW TO READ IT

Galatians is a letter of urgency. Paul does not begin with thanksgiving. Notice the movement from the defense of the gospel to its meaning to its fruit in daily life.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:21	Paul defends the gospel
1:1-10	No other gospel
1:11-2:10	Paul's call and the Jerusalem leaders
2:11-21	Paul opposes Peter and justification by faith
3:1-4:31	Faith and the law
3:1-14	Abraham and the blessing
3:15-29	The purpose of the law
4:1-31	Sons and heirs
5:1-6:18	Freedom and the Spirit
5:1-15	Stand firm in freedom
5:16-26	The fruit of the Spirit
6:1-18	Bear one another's burdens

Ephesians

The church in Christ

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul. Some scholars question this, though the church has long affirmed Pauline authorship.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 60 to 62, from prison.
SETTING	Written to believers in Ephesus and perhaps nearby churches.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	God has united Jew and Gentile in Christ, and calls the church to live worthy of that calling.
KEY VERSE	Ephesians 2:8-9
IN THIS PLAN	Units 4, 20, 21 and 22; Days 86-790 (9 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that all things are summed up in Christ (1:10), that Christ is the cornerstone of the household of God (2:20), and that the church is his body and his bride (5:25-32).

HOW TO READ IT

Ephesians has two halves: what God has done (chapters 1 to 3) and how we then live (chapters 4 to 6). Watch for the repeated phrase “in Christ” and for the long sentences, especially in chapter 1.

OUTLINE

1:1-3:21	What God has done in Christ
1:1-14	Every spiritual blessing
1:15-23	Prayer for understanding
2:1-10	Saved by grace through faith
2:11-22	One new man
3:1-21	The mystery and the prayer
4:1-6:24	How the church lives
4:1-16	Unity and gifts
4:17-5:21	The old self and the new
5:22-6:9	Households
6:10-20	The armor of God
6:21-24	Closing

Philippians

Joy in Christ

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 60 to 62, from prison.
SETTING	Written to a loved and generous church in Philippi.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Christ is our joy, our example, and our goal.
KEY VERSE	Philippians 4:13
IN THIS PLAN	Units 17, 20, 21 and 22; Days 635-796 (6 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

The hymn in 2:6-11 is one of the clearest statements of Christ's humility, incarnation, death, and exaltation. Paul says that to live is Christ and to die is gain (1:21).

HOW TO READ IT

Philippians is a letter of joy written from prison. Count how many times "joy" and "rejoice" appear. Notice how Paul ties humility and unity to the example of Christ.

OUTLINE

1:1-26	Paul's situation
1:1-11	Greeting, thanks, and prayer
1:12-26	Chains and the advance of the gospel
1:27-2:18	Unity and humility
1:27-2:4	Live worthy of the gospel
2:5-11	The mind of Christ
2:12-18	Work out your salvation
2:19-3:21	Examples and warnings
2:19-30	Timothy and Epaphroditus
3:1-11	Paul's former gain, now loss
3:12-21	Pressing on toward the goal
4:1-23	Encouragements and thanks
4:1-9	Rejoice and think on these things
4:10-23	Thanks for the gift

Colossians

Christ is supreme

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 60 to 62, from prison.
SETTING	Written to a church facing false teaching.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Christ is sufficient and supreme over all things.
KEY VERSE	Colossians 1:15-17
IN THIS PLAN	Units 15, 17 and 22; Days 600-801 (6 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Colossians 1:15-20 describes Christ as the image of the invisible God, the creator and sustainer of all things, and the one who reconciles all things through the blood of his cross.

HOW TO READ IT

Colossians answers a false teaching with a large picture of Christ. Notice the argument: because Christ is supreme and sufficient, you were raised with him, so live that way.

OUTLINE

1:1-14	Greeting and prayer
1:1-8	Thanksgiving
1:9-14	Prayer for knowledge
1:15-2:23	The supremacy of Christ
1:15-23	Christ preeminent
1:24-2:5	Paul's labor
2:6-23	Warnings against empty philosophy
3:1-4:6	New life in Christ
3:1-17	Put off the old and put on the new
3:18-4:1	Households
4:2-6	Prayer and wise conduct
4:7-18	Final greetings

1 Thessalonians

Hope in Christ's return

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 50 to 51.
SETTING	Written to a young church facing persecution.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Stay faithful and hopeful, for Christ will return.
KEY VERSE	1 Thessalonians 4:16-17
IN THIS PLAN	Units 20 and 22; Days 740-804 (4 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul writes about the coming of the Lord Jesus, when he descends from heaven, the dead in Christ rise, and we are with the Lord forever (4:16-17). Christ is the one who delivers us from the wrath to come (1:10).

HOW TO READ IT

Notice that each chapter ends with the coming of Christ. Paul writes to encourage a church that is suffering and worried about loved ones who have died.

OUTLINE

1:1-3:13	Thanksgiving and Paul's care
1:1-10	The faith of the Thessalonians
2:1-16	Paul's ministry among them
2:17-3:13	Longing to see them
4:1-5:28	Living for the Lord
4:1-12	Holiness and love
4:13-18	The coming of the Lord
5:1-11	The day of the Lord
5:12-28	Final instructions

2 Thessalonians

Standing firm until the Day

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 50 to 52.
SETTING	Written to correct confusion about the day of the Lord.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Stand firm and keep working while waiting for Christ.
KEY VERSE	2 Thessalonians 2:15
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 22; Day 809

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Christ will be revealed from heaven with his mighty angels (1:7), and the Lord Jesus will destroy the man of lawlessness by the breath of his mouth (2:8).

HOW TO READ IT

This letter corrects a misunderstanding about the day of the Lord. Notice how Paul balances confidence in Christ's return with the call to steady work.

OUTLINE

1:1-12	Encouragement in persecution
1:1-4	Thanks for their faith
1:5-12	Justice at the revelation of Christ
2:1-17	The day of the Lord
2:1-12	The man of lawlessness
2:13-17	Stand firm
3:1-18	Prayer, work, and closing
3:1-5	Pray for us
3:6-15	Warning against idleness
3:16-18	Benediction

1 Timothy

Order in the church

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul. Some scholars question Pauline authorship of the pastoral letters, though the church has long affirmed it.
DATE	Usually dated in the early 60s AD.
SETTING	Written to Timothy, who is leading the church in Ephesus.
GENRE	Pastoral letter.
THEME	Guard sound teaching and organize the church for godly life.
KEY VERSE	1 Timothy 3:15
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 22; Days 810-813 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners (1:15), that there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus (2:5), and that the church is the pillar and buttress of the truth (3:15).

HOW TO READ IT

1 Timothy is a letter from an older pastor to a younger pastor. Notice how Paul returns to sound teaching, godly character, and the dangers of false teaching and love of money.

OUTLINE

1:1-20	Warning against false teachers
1:1-11	The law and false teaching
1:12-20	Paul's testimony and charge
2:1-3:16	Worship and leadership
2:1-15	Prayer and conduct in worship
3:1-13	Overseers and deacons
3:14-16	The mystery of godliness
4:1-6:21	Instructions for Timothy and the church
4:1-16	A good servant of Christ Jesus
5:1-6:2	Widows, elders, and slaves
6:3-21	Contentment, wealth, and a final charge

2 Timothy

Paul's last letter

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 64 to 67.
SETTING	Paul writes from prison, expecting to die.
GENRE	Pastoral letter.
THEME	Be faithful, guard the gospel, and pass it on.
KEY VERSE	2 Timothy 3:16-17
IN THIS PLAN	Units 1 and 22; Days 2-815 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that Christ Jesus abolished death and brought life and immortality to light through the gospel (1:10), and that the Lord stood by him and strengthened him (4:17).

HOW TO READ IT

2 Timothy is Paul's last letter, written near the end of his life. Notice the urgency: guard the gospel, endure suffering, and pass it on.

OUTLINE

1:1-18	Do not be ashamed
1:1-7	Fan into flame the gift of God
1:8-18	Do not be ashamed of the testimony
2:1-26	Be strong and endure
2:1-13	A soldier, athlete, and farmer
2:14-26	A worker approved
3:1-17	Hold to Scripture
3:1-9	Difficult times
3:10-17	All Scripture is breathed out by God
4:1-22	Preach the word
4:1-8	I have fought the good fight
4:9-22	Personal requests and final words

Titus

Good works that adorn the gospel

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated in the early to mid-60s AD.
SETTING	Written to Titus on the island of Crete.
GENRE	Pastoral letter.
THEME	The grace of God leads to godly living.
KEY VERSE	Titus 2:11-12
IN THIS PLAN	Units 17 and 22; Days 638-816 (3 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul says that Christ Jesus gave himself for us to redeem us from all lawlessness and to purify for himself a people for his own possession (2:14). Our hope is the appearing of our great God and Savior, Jesus Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

Titus is a short letter about how sound doctrine leads to good works. Notice the repeated call to "good works" and to a life that adorns the gospel.

OUTLINE

1:1-16	Appointing elders
1:1-4	Greeting
1:5-9	Qualifications for elders
1:10-16	Rebuking false teachers
2:1-15	Teaching for every group
2:1-10	Older men and women, younger men, and slaves
2:11-15	The grace of God has appeared
3:1-15	Doing good
3:1-8	Saved not by works but by mercy
3:9-15	Final instructions

Philemon

A plea for a runaway slave

AUTHOR	The apostle Paul.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 60 to 62.
SETTING	Paul writes to Philemon about Onesimus.
GENRE	Personal letter.
THEME	The gospel changes relationships, making masters and slaves brothers.
KEY VERSE	Philemon 15-16
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 22; Day 817

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Paul appeals for Onesimus on the basis of love, as one who stands in Christ's place for a debtor, "charge that to my account" (v. 18). The letter pictures what Christ has done for us.

HOW TO READ IT

Philemon is a personal letter and a model of persuasion. Notice how Paul appeals instead of commanding, and how he reframes Onesimus as a brother.

OUTLINE

1-3	Greeting
1-2	The senders and recipients
3	Grace and peace
4-7	Thanksgiving and prayer
4-5	Philemon's faith and love
6-7	Prayer for the sharing of faith
8-16	The appeal for Onesimus
8-11	Appeal for my child
12-16	No longer as a slave but as a beloved brother
17-22	The request
17-19	Charge it to my account
20-22	Refresh my heart and prepare a guest room
23-25	Closing greetings

New Testament: General Letters and Revelation

Hebrews

Christ is better

AUTHOR	Not named in the text. The author is unknown, and several names have been suggested.
DATE	Usually dated before AD 70, though not certain.
SETTING	Written to believers tempted to turn back.
GENRE	Sermon in the form of a letter.
THEME	Jesus is greater than angels, Moses, and the priests, and his sacrifice is final.
KEY VERSE	Hebrews 4:14
IN THIS PLAN	Units 3, 7, 12, 17, 19, 22, 23 and 24; Days 32-839 (17 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Hebrews presents Jesus as superior to the prophets, angels, Moses, and the Levitical priesthood. He is the great high priest and the once-for-all sacrifice who sat down at the right hand of God.

HOW TO READ IT

Hebrews alternates between exposition and warning. Notice the repeated word “better” and the five warning passages. The letter is written as a word of exhortation to endure.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:18	Jesus is greater than angels
1:1-4	God has spoken by his Son
3:1-4:13	Jesus is greater than Moses
3:1-6	Faithful as a Son
4:14-7:28	Jesus is the greater priest
4:14-5:10	A sympathetic high priest
8:1-10:18	The new covenant and sacrifice
8:1-13	A better covenant
10:19-12:29	Faith and endurance
10:19-39	Draw near and hold fast
11:1-40	The hall of faith
13:1-25	Final instructions
13:1-19	Love and obedience
13:20-25	Benediction

James

Faith that works

AUTHOR	James. Tradition identifies him as the brother of Jesus.
DATE	Often dated in the 40s or 60s AD.
SETTING	Written to Jewish Christians scattered abroad.
GENRE	Letter with wisdom teaching.
THEME	Genuine faith produces practical obedience.
KEY VERSE	James 2:17
IN THIS PLAN	Units 1 and 24; Days 4-842 (6 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

James calls himself a servant of the Lord Jesus Christ and speaks of the coming of the Lord (5:7-8). The wisdom he describes, pure, peaceable, and gentle, is the character of Christ.

HOW TO READ IT

James is like a sermon in short sections. Notice the many echoes of Jesus' Sermon on the Mount, and that he is not opposing faith, but showing how genuine faith acts.

OUTLINE

1:1-18	Trials and temptations
1:1-12	Joy in trials
1:13-18	God does not tempt
1:19-2:26	Hearing and doing
1:19-27	Be doers of the word
2:1-13	No partiality
2:14-26	Faith and works
3:1-4:12	Words and wisdom
3:1-12	Taming the tongue
3:13-4:12	Wisdom from above and worldliness
4:13-5:20	Patience and prayer
4:13-5:6	Boasting and the rich
5:7-20	Patience, oaths, and the prayer of faith

1 Peter

Hope in suffering

AUTHOR	The apostle Peter.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 62 to 65.
SETTING	Written to scattered believers facing hostility.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Christians live as exiles with a living hope.
KEY VERSE	1 Peter 1:3
IN THIS PLAN	Units 4, 12, 22 and 24; Days 87-849 (6 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Peter says that Christ suffered for us, leaving us an example (2:21), bore our sins in his body on the tree (2:24), and that we are redeemed with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish (1:18-19).

HOW TO READ IT

1 Peter is addressed to suffering Christians. Notice how he links suffering and glory, and how he calls the church "exiles" and "a holy priesthood."

OUTLINE

1:1-2:10	A living hope and a holy people
1:1-12	Born again to a living hope
1:13-2:3	Be holy
2:4-10	A chosen race and a royal priesthood
2:11-3:12	Living honorably
2:11-25	Submission and the example of Christ
3:1-12	Wives, husbands, and all
3:13-5:14	Suffering and humility
3:13-22	Suffering for righteousness
4:1-19	Living for God
5:1-14	Elders, humility, and greetings

2 Peter

Remember and grow

AUTHOR	The apostle Peter. Some scholars question this, while the church has long affirmed it.
DATE	Usually dated about AD 64 to 68.
SETTING	Written to warn against false teachers.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Grow in knowledge of Christ and hold fast until he returns.
KEY VERSE	2 Peter 3:9
IN THIS PLAN	Units 1, 24 and 25; Days 2-894 (5 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Peter speaks of the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ (1:16), the transfiguration as an eyewitness testimony, and the promise of new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells (3:13).

HOW TO READ IT

2 Peter is Peter's farewell. Notice his concern that readers remember what they have been taught and not be carried away by false teachers.

OUTLINE

1:1-21	Growing in godliness
1:1-11	Make your calling and election sure
1:12-21	The reliability of the apostolic testimony
2:1-22	False teachers
2:1-10	Their judgment is certain
2:11-22	Their character exposed
3:1-18	The day of the Lord
3:1-13	Scoffers and the patience of the Lord
3:14-18	Grow in grace

1 John

Assurance of eternal life

AUTHOR	Traditionally the apostle John.
DATE	Often dated about AD 85 to 95.
SETTING	Written to believers troubled by false teaching.
GENRE	Letter.
THEME	Walk in the light, love one another, and know that you have eternal life.
KEY VERSE	1 John 5:13
IN THIS PLAN	Units 21 and 24; Days 754-860 (5 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

John begins with the word of life that we have heard, seen, and touched (1:1-4), says that Jesus Christ the righteous is our advocate (2:1), and says that God sent his Son to be the propitiation for our sins (4:10).

HOW TO READ IT

1 John circles back to three themes: light and sin, righteousness and obedience, and love. Notice the tests of genuine faith: believing in Jesus, obeying his commands, and loving the brothers.

OUTLINE

1:1-2:2	Walking in the light
1:1-4	The word of life
1:5-2:2	Light, sin, and the advocate
2:3-27	Obedience and love
2:3-11	Keeping his commandments
2:12-17	Do not love the world
2:18-27	Antichrists
2:28-4:6	Children of God
2:28-3:10	Righteousness and sin
3:11-24	Love one another
4:1-6	Test the spirits
4:7-5:12	Love and faith
4:7-21	God is love
5:1-12	Faith overcomes the world
5:13-21	Assurance
5:13-21	That you may know that you have eternal life

2 John

Truth and love

AUTHOR	The author calls himself "the elder," and tradition identifies him with John.
DATE	Often dated about AD 85 to 95.
SETTING	Written to "the elect lady and her children."
GENRE	Short letter.
THEME	Walk in truth and love, and avoid false teachers.
KEY VERSE	2 John 6
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 24; Day 862

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

John warns against those who do not confess that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh (v. 7). The true teaching about Christ is the center of the letter.

HOW TO READ IT

2 John is one page. Notice how it holds together truth and love, and how it warns against welcoming teachers who deny Christ.

OUTLINE

1-3	Greeting
1-2	The elder to the elect lady
3	Grace, mercy, and peace
4-6	Walk in love
4	Walking in the truth
5-6	Love one another
7-11	Beware of deceivers
7	Many deceivers
8-11	Do not receive them
12-13	Closing

3 John

Hospitality for the truth

AUTHOR	The author calls himself "the elder."
DATE	Often dated about AD 85 to 95.
SETTING	Written to Gaius about hospitality for traveling teachers.
GENRE	Short letter.
THEME	Support those who work for the truth.
KEY VERSE	3 John 8
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 24; Day 863

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

John says that the traveling teachers went out for the sake of the name (v. 7). Christ's name is the reason for hospitality and the center of the mission.

HOW TO READ IT

3 John is the most personal of John's letters. Notice the three people: Gaius, Diotrephes, and Demetrius, and the contrast between hospitality and pride.

OUTLINE

1-4	Greeting to Gaius
1-2	The elder to the beloved Gaius
3-4	Walking in the truth
5-8	Support the missionaries
5-6	Faithful in all you do
7-8	Fellow workers for the truth
9-12	Diotrephes and Demetrius
9-10	Diotrephes who loves to be first
11-12	Imitate good, and Demetrius is commended
13-15	Closing

Jude

Contend for the faith

AUTHOR	Jude, who calls himself a brother of James.
DATE	Often dated in the 60s AD.
SETTING	Written to warn against false teachers.
GENRE	Short letter.
THEME	Defend the faith once delivered and keep yourselves in God's love.
KEY VERSE	Jude 24-25
IN THIS PLAN	Unit 24; Day 864

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Jude calls Jesus Christ our only Master and Lord (v. 4) and ends by pointing to the one who is able to keep us from stumbling and present us blameless with great joy (v. 24).

HOW TO READ IT

Jude is a short, urgent letter. Notice the many examples from Scripture and Jewish tradition, and the call to build yourself up and keep yourself in the love of God.

OUTLINE

1-2	Greeting
1-2	Jude, servant of Jesus Christ
3-4	The reason for writing
3	Contend for the faith
4	Ungodly people have crept in
5-16	The danger of false teachers
5-7	Examples from the past
8-13	Their character
14-16	The prophecy of Enoch
17-23	How to persevere
17-19	Remember the apostles' warning
20-23	Build yourselves up and show mercy
24-25	Doxology

Revelation

The unveiling of Jesus Christ

AUTHOR	John, traditionally the apostle John.
DATE	Often dated about AD 95, though some propose the 60s.
SETTING	Written to seven churches in Asia Minor facing pressure.
GENRE	Apocalyptic prophecy and letter.
THEME	Christ wins, evil is judged, and God makes all things new.
KEY VERSE	Revelation 21:5
IN THIS PLAN	Units 22 and 25; Days 803-895 (17 days of reading)

CHRIST IN THIS BOOK

Revelation is the unveiling of Jesus Christ (1:1). He is the first and the last, the lamb who was slain and is worthy, the faithful and true rider, and the bridegroom who returns for his bride.

HOW TO READ IT

Revelation is full of symbols, and most of them come from the Old Testament. Read for the big picture: Christ reigns, the church is called to faithful witness, evil is judged, and God makes all things new.

OUTLINE

1:1-20	Vision of Christ
1:1-8	Prologue and greeting
2:1-3:22	Letters to seven churches
2:1-3:6	Ephesus to Sardis
4:1-5:14	The throne and the Lamb
4:1-11	The throne in heaven
6:1-16:21	Seals, trumpets, and bowls
6:1-8:5	The seven seals
17:1-20:15	Babylon and the final judgment
17:1-19:5	The fall of Babylon
21:1-22:21	The new heaven and new earth
21:1-8	The new Jerusalem
21:9-22:5	The city described